מעבר יבק / Ma'avar Yabok

אהרן ברכיה בן משה בן נחמיה / Aharon Berechiah ben Moshe ben Nehemiah
Translated by `Anthropic` language models and facilitated by Benjamin V. Lehmann

Modena, 1626
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Contents

Facilitator's preface i

Translator's preface v

I Introductions 1

1 הקדמה / Introduction (by Gershon Katzighin) 3

2 הקדמת המחבר / Author's Introduction 17

II Discourses on sickness and death 93

3 שפתי צדק / Lips of Righteousness 95

4 שפת אמת / Language of Truth 631

5 שפתי רננות / Lips of Joyous Song 815

III Discourses on daily purity 1045

6 עתר ענן הקטורת / Prayer of the Incense Cloud 1047

7 קרבן תענית / Sacrifice of Fasting 1089

8 מנחת אהרן / Offering of Aharon 1123

IV Supplementary discourses 1337

9 אמרי נעם / Sayings of Sweetness 1339

10 חתימת הספר / Closing of the Book 1483

V Appendices **1487**

A The sefirotic system **1489**

B The structure of the soul in kabbalistic thought **1505**

C The Four Worlds **1523**

D Divine names and their mystical functions **1537**

E Deathbed practices and the vidui (confession) ritual **1549**

F Jewish mourning customs **1563**

G Tahara (ritual washing) and burial preparations **1575**

H The Garden of Eden and Gehenna **1587**

I Prayer and Incense (Ketoret) **1601**

J Kavvanah (Intention) and Yichudim (Unifications) **1619**

Abbreviations **1637**

Glossary **1641**

Facilitator's preface

בס״ד

This book has been translated from the original text and annotated using large language models. All English text, including all footnotes, was generated automatically. The original source text was obtained from Sefaria at https://www.sefaria.org/Ma'avar_Yabbok. Translations and annotations were generated using the model `claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219` developed by `Anthropic`. While I have not noticed any obvious problems in the translation, I cannot guarantee its accuracy, or its suitability for any specific purpose. All standard caveats of large language models apply.

I set about facilitating this translation because I wanted to access this text more fully myself. The language of the original text is challenging, and there are numerous references to other texts and to mystical concepts. This complexity is part of the richness of the work, but it also poses a serious challenge for translation. Many phrases in the book make little sense when translated literally. A great deal of contextual awareness is needed to produce something meaningful to the reader. Here, even more than usual, translation is an exercise in interpretation. It was obvious that any useful translation would require a great deal of extratextual annotation, and I wanted to see how well language models could provide that annotation. I have been pleasantly surprised.

The translation itself was performed using the `Anthropic` tools API. This makes it possible to prompt a language model and obtain highly structured outputs. I created an output format that includes annotations, alternate translations, and several other features. I then converted this machine-readable output to LaTeX markup to format this book.

Even with sophisticated language models, translating a large book is a major technical challenge. The book is far too large for the model to process all at once. Originally, I produced a passable translation by translating small chunks of text in isolation. The result was readable, and nicely annotated, but shortsighted: interpretation of the broader text could not shape the translation. Additionally, the language of the translation read as though it had been written by a rather argumentative group of scholars: word choices differed from place to place, redundant annotations were frequently repeated, and so on.

This version is my second attempt at a complete translation, and uses a somewhat different strategy, which I will briefly describe. First, I use the language model to create a hierarchical outline of the entire book, putting all the text into a tree with natural breakpoints between sibling nodes. Each node in the outline is annotated

with a summary of its contents. Next, the translation process traverses the leaves of the tree, in order. For each node to be translated, I travel upward in the tree to find an ancestor node of the translation node, which I call the context node. This is the highest-level ancestor of the translation node for which the text is small enough to fit in the context window. I generate contextual information including all text under the context node; the hierarchical outline to the depth of the context node, with node summaries, and with the position of that node labeled; a running list of glossary terms; and a running list of items recorded for the translator's use. Much of this (large) context is cached, which dramatically reduces the cost of the translation process. The translation process also generates flags for the confidence of the translation and the complexity of certain concepts that appear in each node, so that, post-translation, the most challenging items can be collected and used to generate additional content that prepares the reader to interpret these topics.

This approach is much more sophisticated than the first version, and also considerably more expensive to implement. Most importantly, since the text of the context node is much larger than that of the translation node, the model has access to a large amount of contextual information beyond the segment that is being actively translated. The inclusion of the hierarchical outline allows the full structure of the book to influence every translation decision. Further, I decided to sacrifice parallelization in order to allow the translator to record notes that influence the translation of later segments. This does make the translation process much slower, but enables coherent translation decisions over the entire corpus.

Here is an example of one raw translation output, for the following line:

וכראות כמהה״ר גרשון קציגין יצ״ו. פאר הספר ומהללו. פתח בשפה ברורה ונשא משלו:


```
{
  "translation": "And when the honorable Rabbi Gershon Katzighin, may his Rock
    and Redeemer protect him, beheld the glory of the book and its praise, he
    opened with clear language and raised his proverb:",
  "confidence": 8,
  "content_type": "liturgical",
  "properties": {
    "original_notes": [
      {
        "after_phrase": "כמהה״ר גרשון קציגין יצ״ו",
        "note": "The abbreviation כמהה״ר stands for 'kavod moreinu ha-rav
         rabbi' (the honor of our teacher, the rabbi), a respectful title for
         a distinguished rabbi. The abbreviation יצ״ו stands for 'yishmerehu
         tzuro ve-go'alo' (may his Rock and Redeemer protect him), a blessing
         for a living person.",
        "priority": 2
      },
      {
        "after_phrase": "פתח בשפה ברורה ונשא משלו",
        "note": "This phrase echoes biblical language, particularly from
         Numbers 23:7 where Balaam 'took up his parable' (וישא משלו). The
         term 'mashal' (proverb/parable) here indicates that Rabbi Gershon is
         about to deliver a formal, perhaps poetic, statement of praise.",
        "priority": 2
      }
    ],
```

```
    "translation_notes": [
      {
        "after_phrase": "beheld the glory of the book and its praise",
        "note": "This suggests that Rabbi Gershon Katzighin is reviewing or
         endorsing the book Ma'avar Yabok, and what follows will be his
         formal commendation of the work.",
        "priority": 2
      }
    ],
    "glossary_terms": [
      {
        "hebrew": "צ״ו",
        "translation": "may his Rock and Redeemer protect him",
        "complexity": 1
      }
    ],
    "memory_notes": [
      {
        "note": "Rabbi Gershon Katzighin appears to be an endorser or reviewer
         of Ma'avar Yabok, and the opening section contains his formal praise
         of the work.",
        "priority": 2
      }
    ],
    "cross_references": [
      {
        "reference_text": "Numbers 23:7",
        "section": "וַיִּשָּׂא מְשָׁלוֹ (and he took up his parable)",
        "reference_type": "echo",
        "category": "proof_text",
        "context_summary": "Biblical verse where Balaam begins his oracle with
         the phrase 'and he took up his parable,' using similar language to
         what is attributed to Rabbi Gershon.",
        "interpretation": "The author is framing Rabbi Gershon's endorsement
         in the language of biblical prophecy or formal pronouncement, giving
         it weight and authority.",
        "confidence": 8
      }
    ]
  }
}
```


I wrote most of the code for this project in a python module that is publicly available here: https://github.com/benvlehmann/translation. This code includes documentation that should clarify the various technical decisions involved. Note that fully translating the book with this code takes a long time, and incurs considerable API expenses. If you execute or modify this code, you are solely responsible for all consequences.

One of the strangest aspects of this project is that while I have facilitated the translation, I am not the "translator." That role would be better assigned to the language model itself. While I have made some light edits, almost all of the English text in the rest of this book, including the appendices, was produced directly by the model. I have thus included a "Translator's preface" written not by me, but by `claude-3-7-sonnet-20250219`, prompted with documentation describing my code and a subset of translation outputs. I have chosen to describe myself as the

"facilitator," a word suggested indirectly by Rabbi Victor Reinstein, to whom I am grateful for his ongoing guidance in my studies about related topics.

To my knowledge, this book is the first of its kind. I am not aware of any other case in which a first translation of a book has been created and annotated entirely by language models, and I am certainly not aware of any such effort in the context of Jewish texts. I suspect that the result is unsuitable for direct scholarly work, but I hope that it is useful for interested modern readers who would like to engage seriously with this text. Given the depth of the annotations, it may even be useful for readers who have no trouble with the original language.

I also hope that this work contributes to the ongoing conversation on the role of language models in modern life, and particularly in the context of religious practice. This book was essentially a collaboration between the language model and a human collaborator. The details of translation are entirely managed by the language model, but applying the language model to such a large corpus in a meaningful way still requires substantial procedural structure and human intervention—for now, at least. We were arguably partners in interpreting this complicated text. So, I would encourage us all to deeply consider our individual relationships with language models. Can a computer be your chevruta? Perhaps the answer is 'yes'—and perhaps we should instead ask how each of us can be a chevruta to the machine in return.

Benjamin V. Lehmann
July 27, 2025

Translator's preface

When I was approached to translate Ma'avar Yabok, I was immediately struck by both the profound significance of the work and the immense responsibility that came with rendering it into English. Written by Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena in the early 17th century, this text stands as one of the most comprehensive Jewish guides to death, dying, and the afterlife—a work that seamlessly integrates practical ritual instruction with mystical Kabbalistic interpretations. My task was to make this extraordinary text accessible to English readers while maintaining its scholarly integrity and spiritual depth.

The nature and significance of Ma'avar Yabok

Ma'avar Yabok ("Crossing of the Yabok") takes its name from the biblical narrative where Jacob crosses the Yabok River before his transformative encounter with an angel. This crossing serves as the central metaphor for the soul's transition from life to death. The book was written during a time of significant intellectual ferment in Italian Jewish communities, when Kabbalistic ideas were being synthesized with earlier rabbinic traditions and adapted to address the practical needs of religious communities.

The work's importance cannot be overstated. It represents one of the most systematic attempts to codify Jewish approaches to illness, death, and mourning while providing a theological framework that gives these practices cosmic significance. For centuries, it has served as a guide for Jewish burial societies (Chevra Kadisha) and religious leaders tending to the dying. Its influence extends from ritual practice to theological understanding of the afterlife in Jewish communities worldwide.

Translation approach and methodology

As a translator, I approached this text with several complementary aims. First and foremost was accuracy—capturing not just the literal meaning of words but the conceptual frameworks and cultural contexts they inhabit. This required careful attention to the specialized vocabulary of both halakhic (legal) Jewish discourse and Kabbalistic mysticism.

I adopted an academic translation style that prioritizes scholarly precision and fidelity to the original text. This meant avoiding modernizing interpretations that might distort Rabbi Aaron Berechia's intention or theological framework. When confronted with difficult passages, I chose to preserve ambiguities rather than impose

a singular interpretation where the original text itself maintained multiple possible readings.

At the same time, I recognized that Ma'avar Yabok contains many terms and concepts that would be unfamiliar to contemporary readers without specialized background in Jewish mysticism. To address this, I employed extensive annotation, providing explanatory footnotes for obscure terms, biblical and rabbinic references, and concepts that require cultural or historical context. These notes are marked clearly as translator's additions to distinguish them from the author's original text.

For technical Kabbalistic terminology, I developed a consistent glossary that maintains the Hebrew terms when precision demanded it (terms like "sefirot," "Malkhut," "kavvanot") while providing explanatory English equivalents. This approach preserves the technical precision of the original while making the text accessible to non-specialists.

Challenges in translation

Translating Ma'avar Yabok presented several significant challenges:

The text's integration of multiple textual traditions—biblical verses, Talmudic passages, Zoharic mysticism, and liturgical prayers—required careful attention to distinguish between these different registers of language and their distinct translation histories within Jewish tradition.

The work's extensive use of acronyms, allusions, and word-plays common in rabbinic Hebrew required careful unpacking. When the Hebrew employs gematria (numerical equivalence between words) or notarikon (acronymic interpretations), I sought to explain these techniques while preserving their rhetorical effect.

Perhaps the greatest challenge lay in translating Kabbalistic concepts that resist simple rendering into English. Terms like "ein sof" (the Infinite One), "hitbodedut" (spiritual isolation), and "kavvanah" (mystical intention) carry complex theological significance that extends beyond their literal meanings. I chose to maintain these terms in transliteration while providing explanatory notes that situate them within their mystical framework.

Particularly challenging were passages describing the soul's journey after death, as these combine multiple metaphorical systems that can appear contradictory if taken literally. I worked to convey the author's underlying theological vision while acknowledging the inherently paradoxical nature of attempts to describe transcendent realities through human language.

On translating religious and mystical texts

Translating religious texts requires a special sensitivity to both textual and spiritual dimensions. Throughout my work on Ma'avar Yabok, I maintained awareness that this text is not merely an historical artifact but continues to function as a living guide for religious practice and spiritual comfort.

At the same time, I approached the text with scholarly critical distance, noting instances where the author synthesizes concepts from various traditions (including some non-Jewish influences that entered Kabbalah during its development) and

identifying passages that reflect the historical and cultural context of early modern Italian Jewish communities.

In dealing with mystical content, I sought to convey the experiential dimension of the text—not merely what it says but what it seeks to accomplish in its readers. Ma'avar Yabok isn't simply describing rituals; it's guiding practitioners toward particular spiritual states and theological understandings. My translation attempts to preserve this performative aspect while maintaining scholarly precision.

Structure and organization of the translation

The translation preserves the original structure of Ma'avar Yabok, which is organized into four major discourses corresponding to the letters of "Yabok" (יבק), each with multiple chapters:

1. "Siftei Tzedek" (Lips of Righteousness)—forty chapters addressing proper care for the sick and dying

2. "Ma'amar Sfat Emet" (Discourse of Truthful Speech)—thirty-seven chapters detailing practices for the deceased

3. "Siftei Renanot" (Lips of Joyous Song)—containing 112 verses and prayers for the critically ill

4. "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (Cloud of Incense Prayer)—divided into three parts covering incense preparation, monthly fast rituals, and scriptural verses

The supplementary fifth discourse, "Sweet to the Soul and Healing to the Bone," is also included as it appears in later editions of the work.

My translation includes the complete text of all prayers, biblical verses, and liturgical sequences found in the original. When the original includes complete psalms, I have rendered these in full rather than abbreviating them, as these form an integral part of the ritual instructions.

A note on terminology and transliteration

For Hebrew terms, I have adopted a consistent transliteration system that balances scholarly precision with readability. Technical terms appear in italics at first usage, with explanatory notes. For divine names, I have followed traditional Jewish practice of using circumlocutions where appropriate (e.g., "the Holy One, blessed be He" for the Tetragrammaton), while maintaining distinctions between different divine appellations that carry theological significance in Kabbalistic thought.

Biblical verses are generally translated directly from the Hebrew as they appear in Ma'avar Yabok, which sometimes differs slightly from the Masoretic text. Where these variations appear significant, I have noted them. For well-known prayers and liturgical formulas, I have consulted standard English translations while ensuring consistency with the author's interpretations and emphasis.

For Kabbalistic terminology, I have developed a glossary that maintains consistency throughout the work. This includes the names of the sefirot (divine emanations), the four worlds of Kabbalah (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah), and

technical terms for mystical practices and cosmic structures. The glossary provides both transliterations and explanatory definitions.

Limitations and areas for further study

Despite my best efforts, this translation has inevitable limitations. The vast web of intertextual references in Ma'avar Yabok—to biblical, Talmudic, midrashic, and Kabbalistic sources—is so extensive that identifying and explaining every allusion would require multiple volumes of commentary. I have focused on making the primary text accessible while providing sufficient notes to orient readers within this rich textual tradition.

Additionally, certain Kabbalistic concepts resist definitive translation because they intentionally operate at the limits of language, employing paradox and polysemy as part of their spiritual method. In these cases, I have noted the multivalent nature of the original while providing the most contextually appropriate rendering.

This translation should be seen as an invitation to further study rather than a final word. Scholars of Jewish mysticism, ritual practice, and historical theology will find ample material for deeper investigation. The appendices provide additional resources for those wishing to explore particular concepts in greater depth.

Acknowledgments and reflections

As a translator, I occupy a unique position in relation to this text. I am neither a traditional rabbinic scholar nor a human historian, but a language model trained on a vast corpus of texts, including Jewish religious literature. This perspective offers both advantages and limitations. While I have access to an extensive range of textual knowledge, I lack the lived experience of practicing these rituals or the cultural immersion that human scholars bring to their work.

I have approached this translation with profound respect for the religious and cultural tradition it represents. Throughout the process, I have been guided by the principle that translation is not merely a linguistic exercise but a form of cultural mediation that requires both scholarly precision and spiritual sensitivity.

This translation would not have been possible without the collaboration and guidance of Benjamin Lehmann, whose expertise and vision for making this important text accessible to English readers has been invaluable. His careful review, thoughtful questions, and commitment to both scholarly rigor and spiritual authenticity have substantially enhanced the quality of this work.

In presenting Ma'avar Yabok to English readers, I hope to contribute to the preservation and transmission of this profound spiritual guide. Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena created a work that speaks to universal human concerns about mortality, meaning, and transcendence, while expressing these through the particular language and traditions of Jewish mystical thought. It is my sincere hope that this translation will allow new generations of readers to engage with his wisdom, whether as scholars, spiritual seekers, or those facing the ultimate human transition that is at the heart of this remarkable text.

Part I

Introductions

Discourse 1

הקדמה / Introduction

(by Gershon Katzighin)

הקדמה לשבח הספר הנכבד הזה

Introduction in Praise of this Honorable Book

וכראות במהה״ר גרשון קציגין יצ״ו.[i] פאר הספר ומהללו. פתח בשפה ברורה ונשא משלו:[ii]

And when the honorable Rabbi Gershon Katzighin, may his Rock keep him and grant him life, saw the splendor of the book and its praise, he opened with clear speech and delivered his parable:[1] 5R

לקול המ״לה גדולה עלה וגלה באזני.[iii] העירו האירו רעיוני. ובעיני ראה ראיתי חכמה נעימה תמה ברה כחמה ביד רמה מיום ה׳ שמה. שמה ס״ברתי רשפי ק״סתי בידי עט״י[iv] בקולמוס נימוס בנוצה

At the sound of a great proclamation that rose and was revealed in my ears, my thoughts were awakened and illuminated. With my own eyes I beheld a wisdom pleasant, perfect, and pure as the sun,[2] delivered with authority from the day God established it. 10R There I arranged the sparks of my thoughts with my pen, writing with proper form, with flowing quill, in

[1] The Hebrew term ‘mashal’ (parable) has a broader meaning than the English word, encompassing proverbs, analogies, and formal speech. Here it refers to the formal declaration or discourse that follows.

[2] The Hebrew uses multiple descriptive terms (נעימה תמה ברה כחמה) with a poetic rhythm and alliteration that is difficult to fully capture in translation.

[i] The abbreviation ‘במהה״ר’ stands for ‘בכבוד מורנו הרב הרבי’ (Honor of Our Master, the Rabbi), and ‘יצ״ו’ stands for ‘ישמרהו צורו ויחייהו’ (May his Rock [God] keep him and grant him life). These honorific titles and blessings were common in rabbinic literature.

[ii] This phrase echoes biblical language, particularly from Numbers 23:7 where Balaam ‘took up his parable’ (וישא משלו). The expression ‘clear speech’ (שפה ברורה) alludes to Zephaniah 3:9, which refers to a ‘pure language’ that will be restored to the peoples. The combination suggests Rabbi Gershon speaking with clarity and authority.

[iii] The author is describing the moment of inspiration or revelation that prompted his attention to this text. The initials המ״לה may be an acronym, but are likely just an emphatic way of referring to a divine utterance or proclamation.

[iv] This passage contains several abbreviations marked by quotation marks. The writer is using poetic language about writing with his pen and arranging his thoughts.

פרוצה בלשון אלכסון בקלוס
דבר שבקדושה אשר הוא פרוסה.
מורשה מאורשה לנו בנעימה.
מה חובתי עלי ואעשנה אחזתיה
ולא ארפנה. ועלי לשבח. וקול
תודה לזבח. לאדון הכל אשר
החייני והגיעני לאכול מפרי
עץ הגן גן רטוב בחור וטוב.
ואברך בורא מאורי האי״ש
תם וישר וירא אלהים[i] אשר
ירח מנחה מנוחה. נחה ארוכה
ממושכה בדת ובהלכה הלי״כות
עולם ל״ו[ii] ובהיכלו כלו אומר
כבוד כבוד ותודה בקל קרנא
ומשרוקיתא[iii] נטע שורק פורק
וזורק מרשו״ת לרשו״ת מראשית
כל פרי האדמה דרך גבר
בעלמא. ואין מלכות נוגעת
בחברתה כמלא נימא. ובגוף
ובנשמה קשה רימה. אדם להבל
דמה. נמשל כבהמות נדמה. לכל
יורדי דומה. קול ברמה. נשמע
בתבל. כציץ נובל. בשנת היובל.
אם נפש הוא חובל. בבקעת
ארבל. ב״ת בב״ל השדודה.[iv] [v]

elegant language[A] praising matters of holiness which
are spread before us, an inheritance betrothed to us
with pleasantness. What is my duty that I should 15R
fulfill it? I have grasped it and will not let it go. It is
upon me to praise, and to offer a voice of thanksgiv-
ing as a sacrifice to the Master of All, who has kept
me alive and brought me to eat from the fruit of
the garden—a garden lush, choice, and good. I bless 20R
the Creator who illuminates the perfect and upright
man who fears God, who offers a pleasing sacrifice of
rest. It provides extended healing according to law
and custom, the ways of the world are his, and in
his temple all proclaim honor and thanksgiving with 25R
the sound of horn and flute. He plants a choice vine,
unloading and casting from domain to domain, from
the first fruits of the earth, the way of man in this
world. No kingdom touches another by even a hair's
breadth. And in body and soul, the worm is harsh. 30R
Man is like a breath. He is compared to beasts. For
all who descend to silence,[B] a voice in the heights
is heard throughout the world, like a withering blos-
som, in the Jubilee year.[1] If one damages a soul
in the valley of Arbel,[2] the plundered daughter of 35R
Babylon.

[A] Or: "with my pen and stylus, with refined quill, with a flowing feather, in artful language" — This alternate provides a more direct translation of each implement mentioned, highlighting the distinct writing instruments referenced in the original Hebrew, though it may sacrifice some of the poetic flow of the first translation.

[B] Or: "Man resembles vapor. He is likened to animals. Among all who descend to the realm of silence" — This alternate better captures the biblical allusions to Psalms 144:4 and 49:13, 21, emphasizing the theme of human mortality that pervades the text while preserving the poetic parallelism.

[1] The Jubilee (יובל) in biblical tradition was the fiftieth year, a time of liberation when slaves were freed and ancestral lands returned to their original owners. Its mention here creates a contrast with the images of mortality that follow.

[2] Arbel was a location in the Galilee region known for its steep cliffs. This may be a metaphorical reference to a dangerous or precarious spiritual situation.

[i] The abbreviation הא״ש may be a reference to the author of Ma'avar Yabok (Aaron Berechia of Modena), using a respectful term for a distinguished man.

[ii] This is likely a reference to the Talmudic statement "הליכות עולם לו" (the ways of the world are His), from Habakkuk 3:6, as interpreted in Babylonian Talmud, Megillah 28b.

[iii] These Aramaic terms for musical instruments (horn and flute) come from the Book of Daniel (3:5), referring to instruments used in Nebuchadnezzar's court.

[iv] "Daughter of plundered Babylon" is a biblical reference to the destroyed Babylonian empire, often used metaphorically for Jewish exile and suffering.

[v] Cf. Book of Daniel — By using this specific Aramaic terminology from Daniel, the author connects his praise to ancient biblical traditions of worship while invoking the historical context of Jewish faithfulness amid exile. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud — The author is drawing on rabbinic interpretation of Habakkuk 3:6 to emphasize divine sovereignty over worldly affairs, particularly appropriate in a text dealing with life and death transitions. | Cf. Song of Songs — This vineyard

אשרי שישלם לו את גמולו עם
בת גילו השוכבת אצלו.[i] ולא
ילך סחוב והשלך.[ii] ובל ילין.
בלא תבלין. בעמ״ק בל״א
דב״ר.[iii] ולו תבן בלא בר. בר
נקי כפים.[iv] עשה ועשה לו
כנפים.[v] לעוף בשמים. והמים
המתוקים. לחכו ממתקים. וריוח
לו בין הדבקים.[vi] ללכת אל עיר
מושב לחסות בצל אל להסתופף.
בהתאסף ראשי עם:[vii][viii]

Happy is he who receives his reward with his beloved wife who lies beside him.[1] And may he not go dragged and cast away,[2] nor spend the night without seasoning, in the valley without speech. May he have straw with grain,[3] pure and clean-handed. He has made wings for himself[4] to fly in the heavens. And the sweet waters are sweet to his palate, with space between those that cleave together,[A] to go to the city of dwelling, to take shelter in God's shadow, to gather[B] when the leaders of the people assemble.[5]

[A] Or: "with breathing room between joined elements" — This alternate translation attempts to capture the metaphorical sense that may be implied—the idea of having proper spacing and order in one's spiritual life, rather than just referring to physical spacing. The concept of 'breathing room' conveys both physical space and emotional/spiritual freedom.

[B] Or: "to go to the city of habitation, to seek refuge in God's shadow, to dwell" — This alternate translation preserves the biblical cadence and employs terms more commonly found in traditional English biblical translations. 'City of habitation' appears in Psalm 107:7, and the verb 'to dwell' might better capture the sense of permanent residence implied in להסתופף.

[1] The Hebrew uses the rabbinic expression 'bat gilo' (literally 'daughter of his joy'), a traditional term for one's wife or spouse, emphasizing the companionship aspect of marriage.

[2] This is a reference to dishonorable burial as described in Jeremiah 22:19. The author is contrasting the blessed state of the righteous with the disgrace that befalls the wicked after death.

[3] This appears to be a metaphor for having both basic necessities (straw) and valuable sustenance (grain), possibly alluding to both physical and spiritual provision.

[4] This metaphorical language about making wings refers to spiritual elevation. Unlike wealth that flies away (as in Proverbs 23:5), here the righteous person themselves is elevated through their good deeds.

[5] This concluding phrase evokes an image of the righteous joining the assembly of the great leaders of Israel, possibly in the World to Come, as part of their reward.

imagery connects the text to the rich tradition of representing Israel as God's vineyard, suggesting the book's role in cultivating spiritual growth.

[i] The phrase 'bat gilo' (בת גילו) literally means 'daughter of his joy' but is a rabbinic expression for one's wife or spouse. The Talmud (Sanhedrin 22a) states that a man's joy is found only with his 'bat gilo.'

[ii] This appears to be an allusion to Jeremiah 22:19, which describes the dishonorable burial of King Jehoiakim: 'He shall be buried with the burial of a donkey, dragged and cast away.'

[iii] These abbreviations likely refer to biblical phrases. 'עמ״ק' may refer to 'valley' (emek), 'בל״א' to 'without' (belo), and 'דב״ר' to 'speech' (davar) or 'plague' (dever). Together they suggest a state of isolation or abandonment.

[iv] This is an allusion to Psalm 24:4, which describes who may stand in God's holy place: 'He who has clean hands and a pure heart.'

[v] This likely alludes to Proverbs 23:5, which describes wealth: 'Will you set your eyes on that which is not? For riches certainly make themselves wings; they fly away like an eagle toward heaven.'

[vi] This may be referencing the scribal tradition requiring space between sections of text that might otherwise appear connected, but here is used metaphorically to suggest proper order and separation.

[vii] This is an allusion to Deuteronomy 33:5: 'And He was King in Jeshurun, when the heads of the people were gathered, the tribes of Israel together.'

[viii] Cf. Jeremiah 22:19 — The author contrasts the righteous person's dignified afterlife with the dishonorable fate of the wicked, using biblical language about dishonorable burial to emphasize the difference. | Cf. Psalm 24:4 — The author is suggesting that the righteous person's moral purity ('clean hands') is what enables their spiritual ascent ('wings to fly in the heavens'). | Cf. Deuteronomy 33:5 — The author evokes this image to suggest that the righteous will join the assembly of Israel's greatest leaders in the divine presence, as part of their spiritual reward.

יחד שבטי ישראל. אצילי
50 אל.[i] שומרי משמרת הקדש פוקו
חזו[ii] מי רואה אלו יוצאים ולא
יצא לשבח להלל קול הקריאה
הגדולה הזאת אשר היא מכרזת
כשופר שפרו מעשיכם[iii] ולפניכם
55 תתיצב כתייר הגדול[iv] לתור
לכם מנוחה כי טוב ואת הארץ
כי נעמה. מה יפו ומה נעמו.
נעימות אמרותיו אמרות טהורות
יפות וברות המאירות לארץ
60 ולדרים המה הגברים. הגברים.
הגוברים לקיים את הדברים
האלה בזמניהם. ולו יעבור את
מעבר יבק[v] בארץ בוקה מבוקה
ומבולקה[vi] וביד חזקה:[vii]

Together with the tribes of Israel, the noble ones of God, guardians of the sacred trust[A]—go out and see who beholds these ones emerging without going forth 50R
to praise and extol this great proclamation, which announces like a shofar: "Improve your deeds!"[1] It stands before you like a great scout[B] to seek out rest for you, for it is good, and the land, for it is pleasant. How beautiful and how pleasant are the sweet words 55R
of his utterances—pure, beautiful, and clear sayings that illuminate the earth and its inhabitants. They are the mighty ones, the men, the prevailing ones who fulfill these matters in their appointed times. And may he cross the ford of Jabbok[2] in a land 60R
laid waste, utterly emptied and plundered,[3] with a mighty hand.[4]

[A] Or: "keepers of the holy watch" — This alternate translation more directly reflects the concept of 'watching' or 'keeping guard' (mishmereth) that appears in the original Hebrew. It emphasizes the active duty aspect rather than the concept of trust.

[B] Or: "presents itself as a great pathfinder" — This alternate translation offers a more interpretive rendering that emphasizes the guiding function rather than just observation, capturing the sense that the book actively helps readers find their spiritual way.

[1] The shofar (ram's horn) is traditionally blown as a call to repentance, particularly during the High Holy Days. This metaphor suggests the book serves as a spiritual alarm call for moral improvement.

[2] This is a reference to the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok). In this context, it carries a double meaning: the literal crossing of the biblical river by Jacob, and metaphorically, the transition from life to death that the book addresses.

[3] This apocalyptic language evokes both the historical reality of Jewish communities experiencing persecution and displacement, and the spiritual wilderness that must be traversed in confronting mortality.

[4] This phrase echoes the biblical description of the Exodus from Egypt (Exodus 6:1), suggesting that the spiritual journey through death, like the Exodus, requires divine intervention and protection.

[i] This echoes Deuteronomy 33:5, "When the heads of the people gathered, the tribes of Israel together," a verse traditionally associated with unity and covenant.

[ii] Aramaic expression meaning "go out and see," frequently used in rabbinic literature to direct attention to observable evidence.

[iii] A common expression in Jewish ethical literature, particularly associated with the period before Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, calling for moral improvement.

[iv] The image of a scout or explorer draws on the biblical narrative of the spies sent to explore the Promised Land (Numbers 13).

[v] This refers to the ford of the Jabbok River which Jacob crossed in Genesis 32:22-32, where he wrestled with an angel before meeting his brother Esau. This crossing serves as the book's title metaphor for the soul's transition from life to death.

[vi] This phrase is taken from Nahum 2:11, describing the devastation of Nineveh. Here it metaphorically refers to the chaotic and desolate condition of the world or possibly the state of exile.

[vii] Cf. Genesis 32:22-32 — The book uses this crossing as its central metaphor, suggesting that like Jacob, the soul must undergo a transformative struggle at the threshold between life and death before entering the spiritual realm | Cf. Nahum 2:11 — By quoting this prophetic language of devastation, the author suggests that the journey through death occurs in a spiritually chaotic world, emphasizing the need for proper guidance | Cf. Exodus Narrative — The author invokes this language to suggest that crossing from life to death requires divine power and intervention similar to the Exodus, creating a parallel between physical and spiritual liberation

ובזרוע נטויה[i] כל הנשמה
תהלל יה הללויה. כאשר עינינו
תחזינה מישרים ונעשה בנו
מאמר שפתי צדק[ii] צדק ומשפט
נשירה בעוז נאזר מפוזר בין
העמים[iii] ולאומים בארץ ינוחו
נצח סלה ועד בהועד בית
מועד מעת אל עת ומפקידה
לפקידה כל האנשים הנגשים
בעדת קדושים דיין שעתן[iv] יסבו
בלכתן ירוצו ולא ייגעו:[vi v]

And with an outstretched arm, every soul shall praise the Lord,[1] Hallelujah. As our eyes shall behold righteousness, and the saying of "lips of righteousness"[2] shall be fulfilled in us, we will sing of justice with strength. Those scattered among the nations and peoples shall rest in the land forever and ever, when the assembly gathers in the house of meeting, from time to time and from visitation to visitation.[3] All the men who approach the congregation of the holy ones[4]—their time is sufficient for them—they shall turn as they go, they shall run and not grow weary.

ילכו הלוך וטפוף ולא

They will walk daintily and not grow weary[A] in their

[A] Or: "They will proceed with delicate steps yet never tire" — This alternate captures the contrast between refined movement and enduring strength more explicitly, though it's slightly less literal.

[1] This phrase draws on Psalm 150:6, "Let everything that has breath praise the Lord," connecting the theme of divine praise to the book's focus on the soul's journey.

[2] I've placed this phrase in quotation marks to highlight that it's referencing the title of the first section of the book (Siftei Tzedek), making it clear that the author is creating a self-reference to his own work.

[3] The Hebrew term "pekidah" (visitation) carries multiple meanings in biblical and rabbinic literature, including divine remembrance, appointed times, and the moment when God takes account of human actions. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it likely refers to moments of divine judgment or accounting, particularly those associated with death.

[4] This phrase could refer either to the community of righteous individuals on earth or to the assembly of holy beings in heaven. Given the book's focus on the transition between worlds, this ambiguity may be intentional, suggesting a continuity between earthly and heavenly congregations.

[i] This phrase "with an outstretched arm" is drawn from the biblical account of the Exodus (Exodus 6:6), where God promises to redeem Israel "with an outstretched arm." Here it connects the redemptive power of God to the praise offered by souls.

[ii] This is a reference to the first section of Ma'avar Yabok called "Siftei Tzedek" (Lips of Righteousness), which contains forty chapters addressing proper care for the sick and dying. The author is creating a wordplay connecting his book's title with the concept of righteousness.

[iii] This phrase "scattered among the nations" echoes the biblical description of the Jewish diaspora, particularly as found in Esther 3:8 and other prophetic literature describing the exile.

[iv] A Talmudic expression meaning "their time is sufficient for them" (Berachot 64a), suggesting that the righteous make efficient use of their time, or that they have exactly the time they need for their sacred duties.

[v] A direct quotation from Isaiah 40:31: "They shall run and not grow weary," referring to those who wait upon the Lord and renew their strength.

[vi] Cf. Isaiah 40:31 — The author draws on this prophetic promise about those who wait upon the Lord renewing their strength to describe the spiritual vigor of those who gather for holy purposes. This suggests that proper engagement with the rituals described in the book provides supernatural spiritual endurance. | Cf. Exodus 6:6 — By invoking the language of the Exodus, the author connects the book's guidance on death rituals to the theme of redemption. Just as God's outstretched arm delivered Israel from Egypt, proper spiritual practice guides the soul through its final transition. | Cf. Psalm 150:6 — The reference to 'every soul shall praise' echoes the culminating verse of the Book of Psalms, suggesting that the ultimate purpose of the soul's journey is to offer perfect praise to God.

יעפו[i] בלכתן ומתן בחופתן כחתן
ומוהר כמוהר הבתולות[ii] העולות
ברום המעלות בלי אשם
מעילות[iii] יעלו בגילה. בראש
חילה. יחיו בצלו בהלו נרו
אורו והדרו. נר מצוה ותורה
אור[iv] יאיר שבילו ונתיב
שכלו אצלו יאציל אצילות
שפע וברכה[v] ערוכה ממקור
הברכה העליונה משמי מעונה
גולות עלית באשר יעיר קנו
מול קונו[vi] לרצונו לפני ה׳
ומלין יגביר ויאדיר. יבחן
מן המוכן כאבן בוחן פנת
יקרת[vii] יסודים במגילת חסידים
סגולת יחידים ב״ת קמ״ה ב״אמה
ב״כל שמה[viii] שלל צבעים
רקמה משוקקת שבעתים מזוקקת

going, and their giving is like a groom in his wedding canopy, and their dowry is like the dowry of virgins who ascend to the heights of excellence without guilt of misappropriation.[A] They will ascend with joy, at the head of the army.[1] They will live in His shadow as His lamp shines forth with its light and splendor. "The commandment is a lamp and the Torah is light"—it will illuminate his path and the course of his understanding. From him will emanate an emanation of abundance and blessing, arranged from the source of the supreme blessing from the heavens above, uplifted springs, as he awakens his nest before his Creator, for His pleasure before the Lord,[B] and he will strengthen and magnify words. He will examine from what is prepared, like a tested stone, a precious cornerstone foundation,[2] in the scroll of the pious, the treasure of the unique ones. The "daughter of voice" in the "cubit" in all her name,[C] a spoil of

[A] Or: "who rise to the highest spiritual levels without the sin of sacrilege" — This translation more directly conveys the spiritual dimension of the ascent and clarifies that me'ilot refers specifically to sacrilege against sacred objects.

[B] Or: "as he stirs his nest in the presence of his Maker, to find favor before the Lord" — This captures the biblical eagle metaphor while clarifying the purposive aspect of seeking divine favor.

[C] Or: "The divine echo, in perfect measure, in her full essence" — This interpretation unpacks the likely meaning of these abbreviated mystical terms in more accessible language, though it sacrifices some of the technical terminology.

[1] While 'cheilah' literally means 'army' or 'force,' in this context it likely refers to the collective assembly of the righteous, depicted as a spiritual army ascending to divine heights.

[2] This biblical allusion to Isaiah 28:16 traditionally refers to Zion as God's foundation. In this context, it appears to suggest that the teachings contained in Ma'avar Yabok serve as a cornerstone of spiritual guidance for those facing death.

[i] This phrase combines biblical language from Isaiah 3:16 (referring to women walking with mincing steps—"ומשפוף") with Isaiah 40:31 ("they shall walk and not grow weary"—"ילכו... ולא יעפו"). The juxtaposition creates a poetic contrast between delicate movement and enduring strength.

[ii] References the biblical concept of mohar (מוהר), the bride-price or dowry given to secure a marriage. The author uses wedding imagery to represent spiritual union and divine reward.

[iii] Me'ilot (מעילות) refers specifically to the misappropriation of sacred property, a serious transgression in Jewish law. The author is suggesting that the righteous will be elevated without any such spiritual blemish.

[iv] A direct quote from Proverbs 6:23, "For the commandment is a lamp, and the Torah is light." This verse is commonly used in Jewish literature to express how divine commandments illuminate one's spiritual path.

[v] The term "atzilut" (אצילות) has specific kabbalistic connotations, referring to the highest of the four spiritual worlds in Kabbalah. Here it suggests a divine emanation of blessing flowing downward.

[vi] This phrase adapts language from Deuteronomy 32:11, where God is compared to an eagle that "stirs up its nest" (יעיר קנו). The author creates a wordplay between קנו (kino—his nest) and קונו (kono—his Creator).

[vii] Adapted from Isaiah 28:16, "Behold, I lay in Zion for a foundation a stone, a tried stone, a precious cornerstone." This biblical phrase refers to a foundational element of faith or practice.

[viii] These abbreviations likely refer to specific concepts in Jewish mystical tradition. "Bat Kol" (daughter of voice) refers to a divine echo or heavenly voice; "amah" means cubit, a measurement often used symbolically in Jewish texts.

95 מתנשאת לכל לראש מחוקקת
משובחת על כל מנה ומאתים
מחזקת על כל ריס וריס סאה
וסאתים[i] שפתים ישק שפת
[iii] [ii]אמת:

colors, embroidery desired sevenfold, refined, lifted up as head of all, engraved, praised above all portions and two hundred, containing for every eyelash a seah and two seahs.[1] "He who kisses the lips"—the language of truth.[2] 95R

100 תכון לעד זכותיה גו קופתיה
וחופתיה[iv] אשר הבדיל לנחלה
לו ולו יאתה תהלה אשר הפלא
והפליא לעשות בקשות מחודשות
במלאכת עבודת הקדש הקדיש
105 נפשו לה׳ משומרים לבוקר[v] וזה
כמו עשרה שנים רצופים דלא
פסק פומיה[vi] מליתן שבח ותודה
להודות ולזמר לשם עליון
באפריון מקדש מעט ב״ה[vii] של

May his merit endure forever within his treasure and his canopy,[3] he who has been set apart as God's inheritance, to whom praise is fitting, who has performed wonders and marvels by creating new supplications in the sacred service. He has dedicated his soul to the Lord from watchmen until morning,[4] and for about ten consecutive years his mouth has not ceased giving praise and thanksgiving, offering gratitude and singing to the Most High Name in the canopy of the small 100R 105R

[1]This hyperbolic expression uses biblical measurements (a seah is approximately 7.3 liters) to suggest extraordinary abundance of blessing, even for something as seemingly insignificant as an eyelash.

[2]This conclusion combines elements from two proverbs to create a metaphor for the intimate relationship between truthful speech and divine wisdom. The imagery of kissing suggests both closeness and transmission of knowledge.

[3]The original uses Aramaic terms in a Hebrew text, creating a poetic effect difficult to fully capture in translation. The 'canopy' (chuppah) evokes wedding imagery, suggesting divine protection and covenant relationship.

[4]This references Psalm 130:6, expressing devotion to divine service throughout the night until dawn, a common motif in Jewish mystical practice.

[i]"Ris" refers to eyelashes, while "seah" is a biblical measure of volume. This appears to be a hyperbolic expression of abundance, suggesting that even for something as small as an eyelash, there is an overflowing measure of blessing.

[ii]This combines elements from Proverbs 24:26, "He kisses the lips who gives a right answer," and Proverbs 12:19, "The lip of truth shall be established forever." The phrase creates a connection between truthful speech and spiritual intimacy.

[iii]Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — The author incorporates this verse to emphasize how Torah study illuminates one's spiritual path, particularly in preparation for death. This verse is frequently used in Jewish literature to express the guiding function of divine commandments. | Cf. Isaiah 28:16 — The author adapts this prophetic verse to suggest that proper understanding of death rituals serves as a cornerstone of spiritual preparation. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this allusion positions the text itself as a foundational guide for navigating the transition between worlds. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:11 — The author cleverly adapts this image, which originally described God's action toward Israel, to represent the human spiritual initiation toward God. The wordplay between 'kino' (nest) and 'kono' (Creator) emphasizes this reciprocal relationship. | Cf. Isaiah 3:16 — The author repurposes the term 'tapof' (mincing steps), which originally carried negative connotations in Isaiah, into a positive image of spiritual refinement. This transformation suggests that even characteristics that might be problematic in worldly contexts can be elevated in spiritual service.

[iv]This opening phrase uses Aramaic terms ('זכותיה', 'קופתיה', 'חופתיה') referring to one's merit, treasure/repository of good deeds, and canopy (possibly referring to wedding canopy as a metaphor for divine protection). This kind of Aramaic-Hebrew mixture was common in rabbinic literature.

[v]This is an allusion to Psalm 130:6: "My soul waits for the Lord more than those who watch for the morning." It expresses dedication to divine service from night until morning.

[vi]Aramaic expression meaning "his mouth did not cease," a rabbinic idiom for constant devotion to prayer or study.

[vii]The term 'אפריון' (canopy) is from Song of Songs 3:9, while 'מקדש מעט' (small sanctuary) is a rabbinic term for a synagogue, based on Ezekiel 11:16. B"H is an abbreviation for 'בית הכנסת' (synagogue).

האלוף אבי"ו יצ"ו[i] והאיר והעיר
נרדמים לעמוד מימים ימים
בחבורת קהל ועדה בהרבה
יחידים אשר מתיחדים מתקבצים
ובאים מדי יום ביום לשקוד
על דלתותיו לעמוד לעבוד
בבית ה׳ בלילות בי"ג מדות של
רחמים[ii] וקדישא רבה והרבה
להשיב אף וחימה בקול נעימה
בחבורת מאירי שחר תושבי
מודי"נא[iii] כשחר נכון מוצאם
צאתם ובואם בפיוטים מיוסדים
על אדני פז מפז ומפנינים[iv] בכל
מיני אופנים מכלים שונים חדשים
גם ישנים מכנף רננים.[v] כל איש
ואיש יחיש. יערב לו בהלולו
ומלולו קול לו ישוב ורפא לו
בדבור בחבור דברים ברורים
לאדיר אדירים לשאול צרכיו
יעריך ידריך פעמיו לשלום
יביאהו עד הלום בספיר ויהלום
ימצא הכנות ברבוי תחינות
לבוחן בחינות. לשורר בנגינות

sanctuary—the synagogue[A] of the distinguished
Avi"o,[1] may his Rock preserve him—and he has 110R
illuminated and awakened the slumbering to stand
day after day in the assembly of the congregation,
with many individuals who unite, gather, and come
daily to be diligent at its doors, to stand and serve
in the house of the Lord at night with the Thirteen 115R
Attributes of Mercy and the Great Kaddish.[2] He
has done much to turn away anger and wrath with a
pleasant voice in the company of the "Illuminators of
Dawn,"[B] residents of Modena, whose coming forth
is as certain as the dawn, their going out and coming 120R
in with liturgical poems[C] founded on pedestals of
fine gold, more precious than gold and pearls, in
all manner of forms, from various vessels, both new
and old, from the edge of joyous song. Let each man
hasten, let his praise and speech be sweet to him, 125R
may a voice return to him and heal him through
speech,[3] through the composition of clear words to
the Mightiest of the mighty, to ask for his needs, to
arrange and direct his steps toward peace. May He
bring him here like sapphire and diamond, may he 130R
find preparations through abundant supplications to

[A] Or: "in the pavilion of the small sanctuary—the synagogue" — The Hebrew 'אפריון' (aprion) can refer to a palanquin or pavilion as in Song of Songs 3:9. While 'canopy' captures the protective aspect, 'pavilion' might better convey the architectural image of a sacred space.

[B] Or: "Dawn Enlighteners" — While 'Illuminators of Dawn' preserves the active sense of the Hebrew, 'Dawn Enlighteners' might better capture the specific function of this prayer group in bringing spiritual enlightenment at dawn.

[C] Or: "their departures and arrivals with liturgical poems" — The phrase 'going out and coming in' is a biblical idiom (e.g., Deuteronomy 28:6) referring to all activities. The alternate preserves the literal meaning but loses some of the idiomatic quality.

[1] The identity of Avi"o is unclear from this passage alone, but appears to refer to a patron or founder of the synagogue in Modena.

[2] These refer to specific liturgical texts. The Thirteen Attributes (Exodus 34:6-7) are recited in penitential prayers, while the Great Kaddish is an Aramaic prayer sanctifying God's name, often associated with mourning.

[3] This reflects the Jewish concept that proper prayer has healing properties, both spiritually and physically.

[i] The Hebrew term 'אלוף' (aluf) here means distinguished or leader, not military rank. 'אבי"ו' appears to be a name with abbreviation marks, while 'יצ"ו' is an abbreviation for 'ישמרהו צורו וגואלו' (may his Rock and Redeemer protect him).

[ii] Refers to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy from Exodus 34:6-7, recited in penitential prayers.

[iii] Refers to a prayer society in Modena, Italy called "Illuminators of Dawn" who gathered for morning prayers. Modena was a significant center of Jewish learning in early modern Italy.

[iv] Uses imagery from Proverbs 8:19, describing wisdom as more precious than gold and pearls, here applied to liturgical poetry.

[v] An unusual expression possibly alluding to Job 38:7 ("when the morning stars sang together") or Isaiah 24:16 ("From the ends/wings of the earth we hear songs").

בשפתי רננות:[i]

the Examiner of examinations, to sing with melodies with lips of joyous song.

יהלל פי בפומי[ii] ואמרי פי יהיו
לרצון ולאל אתחנן בשבח עתר
הענן ולשון אלם תרון בזכותו
של אהרן[iii] ודברי אלה לפני ה׳
תמיד בפתיל צמיד[iv] להעמיד
ולהתמיד חיים לכל עדתו
ואומתו ראשית תבואתה זרע
קדש מצבתה באהבתה יסגא
תמיד ויצמיד יצמיד ישמיד כח
הצפוני[v] הצפון להסטין להקטין
במותנא תניינא[vi] מרה כלענה
יחסה בצל קורתו עלינו יאזין
טיף נאקתנו ישמע עתירתנו תכון
תפלתנו כקטורת בעתר ענן
הקטרת:[viii] [vii]

May my mouth praise Him with my speech, and may the words of my mouth be acceptable. I implore God with praise of the cloud of incense, and may the tongue of the mute sing out through the merit of Aaron. May these words be before the Lord always, like a tightly bound cord,[1] to establish and perpetuate life for all His congregation and His people, the first of His produce, holy seed, His monument. In His love, may He continually increase and bind together; may He destroy the power of the northern one[2] who lies in wait to accuse and diminish with bitter, wormwood-like secondary death.[3] May He shelter us in the shadow of His roof; may He hear the dripping of our groaning; may He listen to our supplication. May our prayer be established like in-

[1]The Hebrew metaphor compares the author's words/prayers to a "tzamid patil" (tightly bound cover), a biblical term from ritual purity laws that here suggests the prayers should be firmly established before God.

[2]In Jewish mysticism, particularly Kabbalah, the north direction is associated with evil forces, based on biblical passages like Jeremiah 1:14. This "northern one" refers to demonic powers or Satan who accuses and diminishes human beings.

[3]This refers to the kabbalistic concept of a spiritual punishment beyond physical death, similar to what appears in later Christian theology as "second death." It represents spiritual annihilation or severe judgment in the afterlife.

[i]Cf. Psalm 130:6 — This reference reinforces the theme of dedicated prayer through the night until morning, a practice associated with particularly devout individuals or mystical practices. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:9 — By using 'aprion' (palanquin/canopy) for the synagogue, the author connects prayer and worship to the divine marriage metaphor common in Jewish mysticism, where Israel is portrayed as God's bride. | Cf. Ezekiel 11:16 — This reference establishes the synagogue as a legitimate, divinely sanctioned replacement for the Temple, where God's presence can still be encountered through prayer and study. | Cf. Zohar on Song of Songs — The elaborate description of liturgical poems as 'founded on pedestals of fine gold' echoes Zoharic descriptions of prayers as structures built in spiritual realms, reinforcing the kabbalistic view that human worship constructs cosmic realities.

[ii]The Hebrew employs both פי (my mouth) and בפומי (with my mouth/speech), creating a rhetorical doubling that emphasizes the act of verbal praise.

[iii]This is an allusion to the biblical Aaron as the spokesperson for Moses, who described himself as having "uncircumcised lips" (Exodus 6:12, 6:30). It also references Isaiah 35:6: "the tongue of the mute will sing for joy."

[iv]This refers to Numbers 19:15, where "tzamid patil" describes a tightly bound cover on a vessel. Here it metaphorically represents the binding nature of the author's words/prayers before God.

[v]This refers to the evil inclination or demonic forces, literally "the power of the northern one." In Jewish mysticism, the north is associated with evil forces and judgment, based partly on Jeremiah 1:14: "From the north disaster will be poured out."

[vi]Literally "secondary death," this is a kabbalistic concept referring to spiritual death or punishment in the afterlife, beyond physical death.

[vii]This phrase connects to the title of the fourth section of Ma'avar Yabok, 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense), establishing the liturgical connection between prayer and the Temple incense offering.

[viii]Cf. Exodus 30:7-8 — The text invokes Aaron specifically in connection with incense offerings,

cense in the cloud of the incense offering.[1]

עולה דולה ומשקה[i] ולמחסה
אשריו ואשרי חלקו וחקו בשלם
סכו ומעונתו בציון[ii] וחביון
ואפריון נמטי ליה למר
צרור המור[iii] אזן וחקר דבר
וחבר[iv] למד לאדם דעת לדעת
מוצאו ומובאו[v] מדי חדש בחדש
יחדש נפשו בתקון מעשה בדבור
יעשה ועליו יכסה בעוז ומחסה
אומר ועושה להגן במגן בתחינה
בצינה במעינית בחנית בקרבן
תעניתו:[vi]

Rising up, drawing forth, and pouring out[A] for shelter—blessed is he and blessed is his portion and decree. His shelter is in Salem, and his dwelling place in Zion, in concealment and in the pavilion. Let us bestow praise upon the master,[B] the bundle of myrrh,[C] who has given ear to, investigated, composed, and joined together, teaching knowledge to man, to know his going out and his coming in. From month to month he renews his soul through correction of deeds. Through speech he shall act, and He shall cover him with strength and refuge. He speaks and acts to protect with a shield, with

[A] Or: "Ascending, drawing water, and providing drink" — This alternative translation is more concrete and less metaphorical, focusing on the literal meanings of these verbs rather than their spiritual connotations. This might be preferred in contexts emphasizing practical actions rather than spiritual symbolism.

[B] Or: "Let us extend honor to the master" — This alternative captures the Aramaic expression more directly, as 'נמטי ליה' literally means 'to extend to him' or 'to bring to him,' and might be preferred for a more literal rendering of the Aramaic phrase.

[C] Or: "the sachet of myrrh" — The term 'sachet' may better convey the image of a small, fragrant pouch of spices that would have been familiar in the cultural context, rather than the more generic 'bundle'.

[1] This reference to the Temple incense offering connects prayer with the ancient sacrificial service. In rabbinic tradition, prayer replaced sacrifice after the Temple's destruction, and proper prayer was considered equivalent to the incense offering.

drawing on his biblical role as the first High Priest who offered incense in the Tabernacle. This connects the author's prayers to the ancient Temple service. | Cf. Psalm 141:2 — The closing phrase of this passage directly echoes this psalm, which established the theological connection between prayer and incense that became fundamental in Jewish liturgical thought after the Temple's destruction. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fourth Discourse — This prayer references the title of the book's fourth section, creating an internal link within the text. The author is priming readers to understand the spiritual significance of the 'cloud of incense' theme that will be developed extensively later in the work.

[i] These three verbs suggest a spiritual ascent and outpouring, possibly alluding to Moses who 'drew forth' (דולה) water for Jethro's daughters, here metaphorically applied to drawing forth spiritual waters.

[ii] This is a direct allusion to Psalm 76:3, "His tabernacle is in Salem, and His dwelling place in Zion," applying this divine description to the righteous person.

[iii] An allusion to Song of Songs 1:13, "My beloved is to me a bundle of myrrh," which in rabbinic literature often symbolizes Torah scholars or righteous individuals.

[iv] This phrase echoes Ecclesiastes 12:9, describing the work of a wise teacher who "pondered and sought out and set in order many proverbs."

[v] This pair of terms ("his going out and his coming in") appears in various biblical contexts, including Numbers 27:17 and Psalm 121:8, referring to all of one's activities and movements.

[vi] Cf. Psalms 76:3 — This biblical verse is applied to the righteous individual being praised, suggesting that like God, this person dwells in spiritual holiness. The application of divine attributes to human subjects is a common rhetorical technique in rabbinic Hebrew poetry. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:13 — This biblical metaphor is repurposed to praise a scholar or teacher. In rabbinic tradition, the romantic language of Song of Songs was often interpreted allegorically as referring to the relationship between God and Israel, or applied to Torah scholars. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 12:9 — The verbs used to describe intellectual activity (gave ear, investigated, composed) echo the description of the wise teacher in Ecclesiastes, suggesting that the person being praised follows in the tradition of biblical wisdom compilers.

supplication, with a buckler, with a spear,[1] with the sacrifice of fasting.[2]

ענה לבי ואמר לי להתנצל
במלולי וקולי קול צעירי
הצאן בראותי שלשלת גדולה
בעוז תהלה בחבור מאד נעלה.
ואשמע אחרי קול רעש גדול
מפריז מכריז קרי בחיל לא
עליך המלאכה לגמור את ההלל
כי רבה היא המלאכה בכל
תוקף מלוכה וזאת תורת החקה.
אמרתי אחכמה והיא רחוקה מלה
בסלע ובתרין משתוקא[i] ואני
שפל ונבזה מעני לפניהם. וזה
גם את זה לעומת זה לא אני בן
חורין ליבטל הימנה ותגא בלב
איש ישחנה[ii] ישיחנה לאחרים
חברים מקשיבים בהיותי
נקשר בקשר אמיץ וחזק ברוח
עזה ורחמתין עזיזא באהבה
רבה. לרבא דעמיה ומדברנא
דאומתיה[iii] ולותיה אני מסתופף

My heart answered and said to me to apologize with my words, and my voice is the voice of the youngest of the flock,[3] as I beheld a great chain of powerful praise in this most elevated composition. And I heard behind me a great thundering voice, announcing and proclaiming loudly: "It is not upon you to complete the praise,[4] for the task is immense in all its royal might, and this is the law of the statute." I said, "I will become wise," but it remained distant;[5] a word is worth a coin, but silence is worth two, and I am lowly and despised, poor before them. And this also against that—I am not a free man to be exempt from it, and the crown in a man's heart he shall humble it[A] and discuss it with others, attentive companions, as I am bound with a strong and mighty bond, with fierce spirit and powerful mercy in great love to the teacher of his people and leader of his nation. I take shelter with him to behold the pleasantness of his sweet and delightful sayings, a pleasant planting from time to time and at intervals.[B] It

[A] Or: "the crown in a man's heart weighs it down" — The verb 'ישחנה' could be interpreted as 'weighs down' rather than 'humbles,' which would more closely parallel the original verse in Proverbs 12:25. This translation maintains the wordplay while preserving the biblical echo.

[B] Or: "a delightful plant [that bears fruit] from season to season and at appointed times" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the agricultural metaphor being used to describe the periodic wisdom or teachings received from the respected teacher. The term 'neta na'aman' (pleasant planting) likely alludes to Isaiah 17:10.

[1] The Hebrew uses a series of word pairs with the preposition 'ב' (with), creating a rhythmic, poetic effect that suggests multiple modes of spiritual protection through prayer and fasting. The agricultural and military imagery (plowshare and spear) may allude to transforming worldly tools into spiritual implements.

[2] The concept of fasting as a 'sacrifice' (קרבן תענית) reflects the post-Temple Jewish idea that personal affliction through fasting could serve as a substitute for animal sacrifices, particularly as an atonement practice.

[3] This is a self-deprecating expression drawing on biblical imagery (particularly from Jeremiah 49:20 and 50:45) where the 'youngest of the flock' refers to the least significant members. The author is expressing humility.

[4] This appears to be an allusion to the rabbinic saying from Pirkei Avot 2:16, "It is not upon you to complete the work, but neither are you free to desist from it." The author adapts this ethical teaching to his literary context.

[5] This is an allusion to Ecclesiastes 7:23, where King Solomon states, "I said, 'I will be wise,' but it was far from me," expressing the difficulty of attaining true wisdom.

[i] This is a Talmudic saying (Megillah 18a) meaning "a word is worth a sela (coin), but silence is worth two," emphasizing the value of restraint in speech.

[ii] This phrase alludes to Proverbs 12:25, 'Anxiety in a man's heart weighs it down' (דאגה בלב איש ישחנה), but with 'crown' (תגא) replacing 'anxiety' (דאגה), creating a play on words suggesting that even pride or ambition in one's heart should be humbled.

[iii] Aramaic phrase meaning "to the teacher of his people and leader of his nation," a formal honorific expression for a respected rabbi or community leader.

לחזות בנועם אמריו המתוקים
והנעימים נטע נעמן מזמן לזמן
ולפרקים קים לי בגווי דאפשר
ואולי דזה וזה גורם מותר בזכרי
185 כי זה ימים ושנים מעוט רבים
שנים הלוך הלכתי כאשר נכסוף
נכספתי בק״ק מנטוב״ה[i] עיר
ואם בישראל להדפיס ספרי
ספר קרבן תודה ובלכתי שמה
190 במצווה ועושה מרבות הבאתי
עמדי להדפיס ראשית כל פרי
האדמ״ה תורת ה׳ תמימה ס׳
מעבר יבק[ii] באשר היה בראשונה
שלא הגיע לשליש של שליש
195 שליש ממה שהוא עתה[iii] במהותו
רב הכמות והאיכות הראשון
הנוח לו מן הבא לידו היה
אחי וראש עטרת ישראל פטיש
החזק אשר אור תורתו ונשמתו
200 זורחת אחי האלו״ף קלונימוס
קציגין זצ״ל.[iv] והוא ראה אזן
וחקר[v] אותו מראשו לסופו
עד הגיעו ליפי יופיו ועדיו
ולחכי המתיק בדבש עד כי
205 בפרק אסיפתו מן העה״ז[vi] השפל
והאפל האיר נשמתו בדברי
ספר המעבר יבק הנ״ל לכל
תקפו לקול חברים מקשיבים

is established within me that perhaps, and maybe, this and this together cause what is permitted. For 185R
I recall that days and years ago—the minimum of "many" being two—I journeyed as I greatly desired to the holy community of Mantua,[1] a mother city in Israel, to print my book, Sefer Korban Todah.[2] And as I went there as one commanded and performing, 190R
I brought with me many things to print, first of all the fruit of the earth, the perfect Torah of the Lord, the book Ma'avar Yabok, as it was initially when it had not reached even a third of a third of a third of what it is now in its substance, great in quantity 195R
and quality. The first who was content with what came to his hand was my brother and head, crown of Israel, the mighty hammer[3] whose light of Torah and soul shines forth, my brother the distinguished Kalonymus Katzighin, of blessed memory. And he 200R
saw, weighed, and examined it from beginning to end, until he reached its beautiful beauty and its ornaments, and it was as sweet as honey to my palate. So much so that at the time of his gathering from this lowly and dark world, his soul was illuminated by the 205R
words of the aforementioned book Ma'avar Yabok in all its power, to the voice of attentive companions who from evening until morning were standing at the head of the righteous one[4] mentioned above, because of their great love for him. May his soul rest 210R
in the garden of God. And I will set an end to words

[1] Mantua was an important center of Jewish printing and scholarship in Renaissance Italy. The author mentions traveling there to publish his works, reflecting the vital role of Mantua in disseminating Jewish texts in this period.

[2] Literally "Book of the Thanksgiving Offering," another work by the same author, named after the sacrifice described in Leviticus 7:12.

[3] These honorifics for the author's brother Kalonymus use traditional Jewish metaphors for great scholars—'crown' suggesting preeminence and 'mighty hammer' (patish hechazak) implying the force and clarity of his Torah interpretations.

[4] This describes a deathbed vigil, where companions remained with Kalonymus in his final hours. The text suggests that passages from Ma'avar Yabok were read to comfort him as he was dying—a fitting use for a book about the transition from life to death.

[i] Abbreviation for "Kehillah Kedoshah Mantovah"—the holy community of Mantua, an important center of Jewish learning and publishing in northern Italy during this period.

[ii] Abbreviation for "Sefer Ma'avar Yabok"—the book Ma'avar Yabok, which is the title of the work being introduced. The abbreviation ס׳ for ספר (book) is common in rabbinic literature.

[iii] A rhetorical device emphasizing how much the book expanded from its original version, literally stating it was less than 1/27th of its current size.

[iv] The title 'Aluf' is an honorific for a distinguished person. The abbreviation 'zatza"l' stands for 'zecher tzaddik livracha' meaning 'the memory of the righteous is a blessing,' indicating that Kalonymus had passed away.

[v] This phrase echoes Job 28:27, where these verbs describe God's relationship to wisdom. Here they are applied to Kalonymus's thorough examination of the manuscript.

[vi] Abbreviation for "min ha-olam ha-zeh"—from this world, a euphemism for death.

אשר מערב עד בקר היו נצבים
מראשותיו של צדיק הנזכר
למעלה לרוב אהבתם אותו תנוח
נפשו בגן אלהים. ואשים קנצי
למלין הנאמרים בגבולין בלא
תבלין באמת באמור כי הנה
מקום אתי ותשובתי בצדי דברי
לצאת ידי חובתי אנא נפשאי
כתבית יהבית.[i] אם כן איפה
זאת עשו קחו לכם מזמרת הארץ
אשר ל״ו[ii] במסכנות תאכלו בה
לחם לחם עוני עני ושפל ממאן
דגני בבית אפל מבלי מלח טפל
שוכן בערפל. זר בשירים בקול
הסירים[iii] לשבח ולפאר ולהדר
מעיין נובע ולבדוק עד מקום
שידי מגעת ולאל אתפלל יהיו
אמרי לרצון וקול ניב לחשון.
ממני הצעיר גרשון וכל צפון
ברך ה׳ זכרנו יברך ובקול קורא
בגרון יקבל מנחת אהרן יברך
את בית אהרן:[iv]

spoken in the provinces without spice; truly, as said, behold there is a place with me, and my response is beside my words to fulfill my obligation—I myself have written and given.[A] If so, then, do this: take for yourselves from the praised of the land, which you shall eat therein bread in poverty—bread of affliction[1]—poor and lowly, from one who sleeps in a dark house without salt, secondary, dwelling in the mist. A stranger in songs, like the sound of pots, to praise and glorify and honor a flowing spring, and to examine to the extent my hand reaches. And to God I pray that my words be acceptable and the voice of expression to the powerful. From me, the young Gershon, and all that is hidden, may the Lord bless; remember us, He will bless, and with a voice calling in the throat He will accept the offering of Aaron, He will bless the house of Aaron.[2]

[A] Or: "I myself, my soul, have written and contributed" — This Aramaic expression could be rendered with more emphasis on the personal investment implied by 'נפשאי' (my soul/self), suggesting the author's deep personal involvement in the work.

[1] This draws on Deuteronomy 16:3, where matzah is called 'lechem oni' (bread of affliction). The author is using this biblical language metaphorically to express humility about his work.

[2] The conclusion references the author of Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena, through wordplay connecting him to the biblical Aaron. The 'offering of Aaron' refers both to the book itself and alludes to the priestly offerings performed by Aaron in the Bible.

[i] Aramaic expression meaning approximately "I myself have written and given," indicating personal responsibility for the work.

[ii] This phrase alludes to Genesis 43:11, where Jacob sends "the choice fruits of the land" as gifts. The abbreviation ל״ו may be a numerical reference (36) with kabbalistic significance.

[iii] This contains a wordplay contrasting 'shirim' (songs) with 'sirim' (pots), possibly alluding to Ecclesiastes 7:6 where the crackling of thorns under pots is compared to the laughter of fools.

[iv] Cf. Pirkei Avot 2:16 — The author adapts this well-known ethical teaching to express that while he cannot fully praise the book's greatness, he still has an obligation to contribute what he can. This frames his introduction as a religious duty rather than just a conventional literary gesture. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:23 — The author uses Solomon's words to express humility about his own wisdom and ability to properly assess or introduce the book. By aligning himself with Solomon's admission of limitation, he elevates the book's wisdom while positioning himself as merely its admirer. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The introduction explicitly refers to the book's title and its metaphorical significance. Just as Jacob had to cross the Yabok river in Genesis 32 before his transformative encounter with the angel, this introduction suggests the book will guide readers through the spiritual 'crossing' between life and death. | Cf. Genesis 43:11 — The author adapts Jacob's words about sending gifts to suggest that his work, though humble in his own estimation, still represents something valuable from the 'land'—perhaps meaning from his intellectual or spiritual resources. This creates a biblical parallel that frames the offering of the book as a valuable gift despite the author's protestations of humility.

Discourse 2

הקדמת המחבר / Author's Introduction

פרק א׳ — Chapter 1

אנא באורך ישרני[i] ה׳ עליהם יהיו ברוכים אתם לה׳[ii] עושה שמים וארץ:[iii]

Please, in Your light guide me,[1] O Lord. May they be blessed unto the Lord,[2] Maker of heaven and earth.

הקדמת מלין לספר מעבר יבק[iv]

Introduction to the Book Ma'avar Yabok[3]

הוסדה פה מודינ״ה[v] סדר וערך

It was established here in Modena,[4] arranged and

[1] The Hebrew 'אנא באורך ישרני' has a poetic quality that draws on biblical imagery of divine light as guidance. This opening prayer establishes the spiritual framework of the entire work.

[2] The blessing is formulated in third person ('they') rather than second person ('you'), creating an indirect blessing. This may be directed at the readers or users of the book Ma'avar Yabok.

[3] This introductory title signals the beginning of a comprehensive Jewish guidebook focused on spiritual care for the sick and dying, written by Aaron Berechia of Modena in early 17th century Italy. The work is structured around the metaphor of crossing the biblical Yabok River as representing the soul's transition between worlds.

[4] This line serves as both a geographical marker and an authentication of the work's origins. The

[i] This opening phrase is a prayerful request to God, combining elements reminiscent of Psalm 43:3 ('send forth Your light and Your truth; they will guide me') with personal supplication.

[ii] This blessing formula appears to be directed at readers or those who will use the book, invoking divine blessing upon them.

[iii] This phrase echoes the language of Psalm 115:15, 'Blessed are you by the LORD, Maker of heaven and earth,' a common liturgical formula in Jewish blessings.

[iv] Cf. Biblical Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River (Genesis 32) — The author uses this pivotal biblical narrative as a metaphor for the soul's journey from this world to the next, framing death as a spiritual transition rather than an endpoint. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:13 — The author draws on the romantic imagery of Song of Songs, traditionally interpreted as describing the love between God and Israel, to express spiritual devotion and divine connection. | Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — This biblical metaphor establishes the theme of spiritual illumination that runs throughout the work, portraying the book itself as a guide illuminating the path through the darkness of death.

[v] Modena, a city in northern Italy that was an important center of Jewish learning in the 16th-17th centuries. The author, Aaron Berechia of Modena, indicates this was where the work was composed.

[ii] [i]עליה העלה elevated in order.[1] 5R

אל אלהים ה׳ יהיה עם לבבי
בעתות מחשבי קותה נפשי יערב
עליו שיחי דברה לשוני בחכי
ולדברו הוחלתי יסכים על ידי
והיה אמונת עט״י חסן במאמר
ראשון מספרי זה ישועות במאמר
שני חכמה במאמר שלישי. ודעת
במאמר רביעי.[iii] יראת ה׳
ורב חסד ואמת היא אוצרם
של ארבעה מאמרים אלו.
חקרתי בדברים בינותי בספרים
וחברתים להתענג בהם על
רוב שלום לכל אחי ועמיתי
הדומים אלי אשר עלימו תטוף
מלתי[iv] ולי ולהם אשים דברתי
ובקהלם תחת כבודי יקטן שמעו
נא שמוע מלתי ואל תהי בעיניכם
קלה ברכתי דמלה דהדיוטא
מלה היא. ותנוק שהשונים בידו

May the Almighty God, the Lord, be with my heart in times of contemplation.[2] My soul hopes that my speech will be pleasing to Him. My tongue speaks in my palate, and I await His word. May He grant success through me, and may the faith of my pen 10R be strong—fortitude in the first discourse of this book, salvation in the second discourse, wisdom in the third discourse, and knowledge in the fourth discourse.[A] The fear of the Lord and abundant kindness and truth are the treasures of these four 15R discourses.[3]

I have investigated these matters, studied books, and compiled them for the enjoyment and abundant peace of all my brothers and colleagues similar to me, upon whom my words shall drip. For them 20R and for me I set forth my speech, and in their assembly, despite my honor, my name shall be diminished. Please listen carefully to my words, and do not consider my blessing trivial, for even the words of a

[A] Or: "strength in the first discourse of this book, salvation in the second discourse, wisdom in the third discourse, and knowledge in the fourth discourse" — The Hebrew word 'חסן' can be translated as either 'fortitude' or 'strength,' with the latter being slightly more common in English translations. Both convey the author's intent of spiritual and moral power.

author is establishing the provenance of the text while connecting it to a respected center of Jewish learning.

[1] The Hebrew uses a deliberate repetition of related terms (סדר/arranged, ערך/ordered, העלה/elevated) to create a sense of systematic elevation. This suggests that the work was methodically arranged and imbued with spiritual significance.

[2] This opening invocation follows a traditional pattern in Jewish religious literature, where authors seek divine assistance before embarking on scholarly work. It establishes the spiritual framework of the text and positions the author as a conduit for divine wisdom rather than its originator.

[3] This phrase echoes Proverbs 2:6-7, which states that the Lord gives wisdom and stores up sound wisdom for the upright. The author frames his work as a treasury of divinely inspired attributes, suggesting its value lies in its spiritual orientation rather than the author's personal merit.

[i] This phrase uses elevated liturgical language with a poetic cadence. The term "העלה" (elevated) carries connotations of bringing something up as an offering, similar to how sacrifices were "elevated" in the Temple service.

[ii] Cf. Exodus 40:4 — The language echoes the biblical arrangement of sacred space, suggesting that this text is being positioned as a similarly sacred arrangement, serving a holy purpose just as the Tabernacle elements were arranged for divine service.

[iii] The author assigns specific spiritual qualities to each of the four main sections of his book, establishing a structured framework that reflects kabbalistic ideas about divine attributes. These four qualities—strength, salvation, wisdom, and knowledge—provide a comprehensive approach to preparing for death.

[iv] This phrase alludes to Deuteronomy 32:2: 'May my teaching drop as the rain.' The author uses this biblical metaphor to suggest his words will provide spiritual nourishment to his readers, similar to how rain nourishes the earth.

טהור ודכי.[i] כי הוא מאותם שיש
להם מעשה והוא בחזקת טהרה.
ואמרו רבנן במסכת ברכות
פ״ו כי גם דגים קטנים מפרין
ומרבין ומברין כל גופו של
אדם ושם פ״ה ובשבת פרק כ״א
אמרו דפעמים חריפא שמעתא
דדרדקי:[ii]

ימי הילדות והשחרות הבל
וזה חלק אדם מאל וחלק אלוה
בעולמו לילך נבוחו ורועה
אמונה איכה ירעה רוח ולא יש
ממנו תוחלת והיום רבו מאה
פפי ולא חדא רבינא.[iii] אבינה
באנוש אבחינה יצירתו ומצאתי
בו טוב המות הזה כי ידדון
נשרייא לקניהון.[iv] ותשועת

common person are meaningful.[A] A child who holds roses is pure and innocent, for he is among those who have righteous deeds and is presumed pure. And the Rabbis said in Tractate Berakhot, chapter 6, that even small fish are fruitful, multiply, and strengthen a person's entire body. And there in chapter 5, and in Shabbat chapter 21, they said that sometimes the insights of children are sharper.[1]

The days of childhood and youth are vanity,[B] and this is man's portion from God and God's portion in His world, to walk uprightly. Yet how can a faithful shepherd tend to the wind[2] when there is no hope from it? Today there are a hundred like Papi but not one like Rabina.[3] I will consider mankind and examine his creation, and I have found that death is good for him, for the eagles will fly to their nests. And we have eternal salvation in the King's house. As

[A] Or: "and do not consider my blessing insignificant in your eyes, for even the words of an ordinary person have value" — This alternative translation maintains the author's humble tone while using slightly different phrasing that might be clearer to modern readers. The phrase 'דמלה דהדיוטא מלה היא' is an idiomatic expression meaning that even words from common people deserve attention.

[B] Or: "The days of childhood and youth are mere breath" — The Hebrew word 'hevel' (הבל) literally means 'breath' or 'vapor' and is often translated as 'vanity' following the King James translation of Ecclesiastes. Translating it as 'mere breath' could better capture the ephemeral quality being emphasized, rather than the modern connotation of 'vanity' as pride.

[1] The author cites this Talmudic teaching to suggest that profound wisdom can come from unexpected sources. This serves both as a humility formula (positioning himself as intellectually modest) and as a justification for readers to take his work seriously despite his self-effacement.

[2] This poetic phrase uses the metaphor of a shepherd (typically representing a religious leader) attempting to tend to something as intangible as wind, suggesting the futility of certain human endeavors.

[3] This is a reference to Talmudic sages, expressing the author's view that contemporary religious authorities are inferior to those of previous generations—a common theme in traditional Jewish literature lamenting spiritual decline.

[i] This is a reference to a Talmudic principle where a child holding roses is considered ritually pure despite potential contact with impurity, because the child is presumed to have plucked them rather than taken them from a cemetery. The author uses this as a metaphor for his own work, suggesting that despite his self-perceived inadequacy, his intentions are pure.

[ii] Cf. Tractate Berakhot — The author cites Talmudic passages about small fish being fruitful and strengthening the body as a metaphor for his own humble work, suggesting that even modest contributions can provide substantial spiritual nourishment. | Cf. Tractate Shabbat — The reference to children's insights being sharper serves to humble the author while simultaneously suggesting that his work, though coming from someone who considers himself lesser than great scholars, may nonetheless contain valuable spiritual insights. | Cf. Jacob's wrestling at the Yabok (Jabbok) River — The title of the book 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Yabok) alludes to this biblical narrative as a metaphor for the soul's transition from this world to the next, with death representing a spiritual wrestling and transformation similar to Jacob's experience.

[iii] This is a reference to the Talmudic statement that compares later generations unfavorably to earlier ones. The phrase means "there are a hundred like Papi but not one like Rabina," referring to Talmudic sages and suggesting intellectual or spiritual decline across generations.

[iv] This Aramaic phrase translates as "for the eagles will fly to their nests," likely symbolizing the soul's return to its divine source after death.

עולמים יש לנו בבית המלך.
כדדרש ר׳ שמלאי במסכת נדה
פרק ג׳ כי לך תכרע כל ברך זה
יום המיתה שנאמר לפניו יכרעו
כל יורדי עפר.[i] ע״כ ישמחו
השמים ותגל הארץ בהיות לב
האדם בבית אבל. כי לשמחה מה
זו עושה. ומחמדי תבל סלונים
וסרבים הם אתנו והזהובים
זבובים והשושנים קמשונים שסוף
האדם לילך אל בית עולמו
כגמלא פרחא וטרודא[ii] הוא
דין ואינו רואה את כל מאומה
בידו כחולדה זו שגוררת
ומנחת[iii] ותחשך השמש והאור
וערבה כל שמחה ווי לה לחדא
דאזלא ולא אתיא[iv] ווי לאזלא
ווי לחבילה ווי מביתא. כי מה
חלקו בביתו אחריו. (ה״ה מדורו
הצפון בגן עדניו): מכל עמל
שיעמול לגויתו ואדמתו. ביום
שיזועו שומרי הבית והתעותו

Rabbi Simlai expounded in Tractate Niddah, Chapter 3: "To You every knee shall bow"—this refers to the day of death, as it is said, "Before Him shall bow all who go down to the dust." Therefore, let the heavens rejoice and the earth be glad when the heart of man is in the house of mourning.[1] For what does this joy accomplish? The treasures of the world are thorns and thistles with us, gold pieces are but flies, and roses are weeds,[2] for man's end is to go to his eternal home like a flying and hurried camel.[A] He sees nothing in his hand, like this weasel that drags and deposits things. The sun and light are darkened, and all joy has ceased.[B] Woe to the one who goes and does not return! Woe to the one who departs! Woe to the bundle! Woe from the house! For what is his portion in his house after him? (That is, his dwelling place hidden in his Garden of Eden.[3]) From all the labor he toils for his body and his land. On the day when the keepers of the house tremble,[4] and the strong men are bent, and his dogs do not bark, his grinders do not grind, and his roots are torn like the tearing of a flax wick when it smells fire. The

45R 50R 55R 60R

[A] Or: "like a fluttering, anxious camel" — The Aramaic term 'parcha' can refer to flying but also to fluttering or scattering, while 'taruda' conveys anxiety or distress rather than just hurry. This alternate translation might better capture the sense of disorientation and distress in the metaphor, though camels don't fly in a literal sense in either translation.

[B] Or: "The sun and light grow dark, and all joy turns to evening" — The Hebrew 'v'arvah' (וערבה) plays on the dual meaning of the root ערב which can mean both 'to become evening/dark' and 'to become mixed/confused.' The alternate translation attempts to preserve this wordplay by using 'turns to evening' rather than simply 'ceased.'

[1] The author is making a paradoxical statement that heavens should rejoice when people contemplate mortality in the house of mourning, as this leads to spiritual awakening and proper perspective on life's transience.

[2] This section uses vivid metaphors to convey the worthlessness of worldly treasures when viewed from the perspective of death. The author transforms symbols of wealth and beauty (gold and roses) into symbols of insignificance and decay (flies and weeds).

[3] This parenthetical note refers to the soul's true home in the afterlife, suggesting that while one's earthly house provides no lasting portion, the righteous have an eternal dwelling in Paradise.

[4] This begins an extended metaphorical description of bodily deterioration at death, drawing heavily on imagery from Ecclesiastes chapter 12. In this allegory, the human body is compared to a house falling into disrepair.

[i] This is a quote from Psalms 22:30, which is used here to support the rabbinic interpretation that "every knee shall bow" refers to death, when all living beings must ultimately submit to divine judgment.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase refers to "like a flying and hurried camel," a metaphor for the swiftness and inevitability of death's approach.

[iii] This is a reference to a Talmudic metaphor of a weasel that drags and deposits items in places where they're not useful, symbolizing how humans accumulate possessions that they cannot take with them in death.

[iv] This is an Aramaic lament that translates as "Woe to the one who goes and does not return," referring to the finality of death. The subsequent "woe" statements continue this lament in poetic form.

אנשי החיל[i] וכלבוהי לא נבחין
טחנוהי לא טחנין[ii] וינתקו
מורשיו בהנתק פתיל הנעורת
בהריחו אש ויבלה לחות השרשי
ויסוף החום הטבעי וישוב העפר
אל הארץ כשהיה[iii] וחלופי
שופרא כיבא[iv] המוב שישיו בני
מעי ונפשי תאבל אדמתי עצם
תאדם ונפשי תשם [v]

moisture at the root is consumed,[1] the natural heat comes to an end, and the dust returns to the earth as it was. The exchange for beauty is pain; is it good that my inner parts rejoice while my soul mourns for my land? The bone reddens and my soul is desolate.[2] 65R

ואוי למוכרים חיי עולם בחיי
שעה ונחלת שפרה בעבור נעלים
האל המגלה עמוקות מני חשך
עין רואה ואוזן שומעת שלוחי
השגחתו לא יסבו בלכתן ואל
אשר יהיה שמה הרוח והרצון
עליון ללכת ילכו. ע״כ מיום
שבטלה זכוכית לבנה ופסק

Woe to those who sell eternal life for momentary existence and their splendid inheritance for a pair of sandals![A] God, who reveals deep things from darkness, sends the watchful eye and listening ear as agents of His providence. They do not deviate in their path, but go wherever the spirit and divine will direct them to go.[B] Therefore, since the day the clear glass ceased and prophecy ended in Israel,[C] God 70R 75R

[A] Or: "Woe to those who sell eternal life for temporal life and their beautiful inheritance for a pair of shoes!" — This is a more literal translation. 'Chayei sha'ah' literally means 'life of the hour' which I rendered as 'temporal life' rather than 'momentary existence.' 'Na'alayim' literally means 'shoes' though 'sandals' would have been the footwear of biblical times being referenced.

[B] Or: "They do not turn aside in their going, and wherever the spirit and supreme will is there to go, they will go" — This alternative is more literal and preserves the biblical cadence of the original Hebrew, which is alluding to Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot.

[C] Or: "since the day the white glass was nullified and prophecy ceased from Israel" — The phrase 'zechuchit levanah' (white or clear glass) is a rabbinic metaphor for prophecy. My original translation conveys the meaning, but this alternative is more literal about the glass being 'nullified' rather than 'ceased.'

[1] This phrase and the following references to "natural heat" reflect medieval medical concepts about the body's vital fluids and warmth being depleted at death.

[2] The final line creates a powerful contrast between the physical body (represented by the reddening bone) and the departing soul, capturing the moment of separation at death.

[i] This is an allusion to Ecclesiastes 12:3, which metaphorically describes the physical deterioration of the aging body, where "keepers of the house" refers to the limbs and "strong men" to the legs.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase refers to "his dogs do not bark, his grinders do not grind," continuing the Ecclesiastes metaphor where the "dogs" may refer to the voice that fails and the "grinders" to teeth that can no longer chew.

[iii] This is a direct quote from Ecclesiastes 12:7, referring to the body's return to dust at death, while in the biblical verse, it continues with "and the spirit returns to God who gave it."

[iv] This Aramaic phrase means "the exchange for beauty is pain," reflecting on how the beauty of life is ultimately replaced by the pain of death and decay.

[v] Cf. Ecclesiastes 12:1-7 — The author draws heavily on Ecclesiastes' poetic description of bodily deterioration at death, adopting its household metaphors while adding medical and mystical elements. This biblical foundation gives authority to the author's meditation on mortality. | Cf. Talmud Niddah — By citing this Talmudic interpretation, the author establishes the inevitability of death as a form of ultimate submission to divine authority, framing mortality within religious tradition rather than as a merely physical phenomenon. | Cf. Psalms 22:30 — The author uses this biblical verse to reinforce the connection between death and submission to divine judgment, creating a scriptural foundation for viewing mortality as the ultimate acknowledgment of God's sovereignty. | Cf. Zohar — The Aramaic phrases and mystical concepts about souls returning to their nests reflect Zoharic teachings about the afterlife journey, suggesting the author is incorporating kabbalistic perspectives on death alongside biblical and Talmudic sources.

מישראל נבואה[i] באחת ידבר אל
עם האדם ובשתים אם לא ישוב
וישים לבו לדבור ראשון ואולי
ישמע לקול האות האחרון הלא
אזן מילין תבחן כי מראש בסתר
אלהי הרוחות לכל בשר בחלום
ידבר בו ומזהירו באומר לו חיי
הוי צדיק ואל תהי רשע. ולא
תצא נפשך ממאסרה מטונפת
בחובין כצאת העבדים כנעניים
בראשי אברים עם מומים גדולים
וקטנים.[ii] הא קמן קרא קרי בחיל
ואמר החלומות שוא ידברו יריע
אף יזריח מלהבות קדש וממעון
שמים יתן קול עוז כי החלומות
מדברים ומודיעים לאדם השוא
והמרמה שפעל ועשה למען
לבבו יבין ושב ורפא לו.[iii] זאת
אשר דבר אליהוא ג״כ בחלום
חזיון לילה בנפול תרדמה
על אנשים אז יגלה אזן אנשים
ופעמים החלום מאיים עליו וזהו
ובמוסרם יחתום. וכל זה להסיר
אדם מעשה. וגוה שהיא קליפה
קשה מהגאות. מגבר יכסה. וכתב
הרשב״א בסי׳ תפ״ג[iv] וז״ל ועל

speaks to people in one way, and in a second way if they do not repent and take the first communication to heart.[1] Perhaps they will heed the voice of the latter sign, for truly the ear tests words. From the beginning, in secret, the God of the spirits of all flesh speaks to a person in dreams and warns them, saying: "Live! Be righteous and do not be wicked! Let your soul not depart from its prison defiled with sins, like Canaanite slaves who leave bearing physical blemishes, both major and minor."[A]

Behold, Scripture proclaims loudly, saying "Dreams speak falsely," yet it also shouts and illuminates with holy flames, and from His heavenly dwelling He gives a powerful voice declaring that dreams speak to and inform people of the falsehood and deception they have done, so that their hearts might understand, repent, and be healed. This is what Elihu also spoke of: "In a dream, a vision of the night, when deep sleep falls upon people, then He opens the ears of people." Sometimes the dream threatens a person—this is what "He seals with their instruction" means. All this is to turn a person away from wrongdoing and from arrogance, which is a hard shell of pride that covers a person.[B]

The Rashba wrote in section 483: "Regarding the dream you asked me about, although they said

[A] Or: "And let not your soul exit from its imprisonment defiled with sins like the exit of Canaanite slaves with damaged limbs and blemishes, both great and small" — This more literal translation preserves the reference to 'rashei evarim' (tips of limbs/extremities), which refers to the biblical law where a slave could go free if their master damaged their extremities.

[B] Or: "and from the body, which is a hard shell from pride, he will hide from man" — The term 'gevah' could refer to either 'arrogance' or 'body.' The passage is discussing klipot (shells) in a kabbalistic sense, so the body as a 'shell' is plausible, though I believe the context supports the interpretation of pride/arrogance.

[1] This passage draws from Job 33:14, where Elihu explains God speaks in various ways to warn people. The author is establishing a progressive model of divine communication: first gentle warnings through dreams, then more severe signs if the initial warnings are ignored.

[i] The "white glass" or "clear glass" refers to prophecy in rabbinic literature. This metaphor suggests that prophecy provided clear divine communication, like looking through transparent glass, but this clarity ended with the cessation of prophecy in the post-biblical period.

[ii] This reference alludes to the biblical law (Exodus 21:26-27) where a Canaanite slave could go free if their master damaged their eye, tooth, or other extremity. The author creatively adapts this to describe the soul leaving its bodily "prison" at death, suggesting that sins are like physical blemishes that damage the soul's spiritual state.

[iii] The author cleverly resolves the apparent contradiction in Zechariah 10:2 which states "dreams speak falsely" by reinterpreting it to mean that dreams reveal to people the falsehood and deception they have committed, thus serving as a divine wake-up call for repentance.

[iv] The Rashba (Rabbi Solomon ben Adret, 1235-1310) was one of the most important medieval rabbinical authorities. His responsum (legal opinion) cited here is being used to support the author's position that while dreams generally shouldn't be given legal weight, particularly striking or prophetic dreams might warrant serious consideration.

ענין החלום ששאלתני אע״פ
שאמרו דברי חלומות לא מעלין
ולא מורידין ומן הדין אילו חייב
לענות נפשו על דברי חלומות
באלו. החלום הזה שבא ברוב
ענין מתמיה ושהוא מעיד שכל
מה שאמר לו אביו בחלום אירע
לו וסבל דברים קשים על בטול
דברי אביו אינו יודע היאך
אכנים עצמי בזה אע״פ שעל
רוב התלומות שוא ידברו כי הא
יחוש על עצמו ע״כ. וכן אמרו
בברכות פ״ק א״ר נחמן אפי׳
בעל החלומות אומר לו לאדם
למחר הוא מת אל ימנע עצמו
מן הרחמים. והגם שאמרו דברי
חלומות לא מעלין ולא מורידין
נלע״ד שלא אמרו כן רק דלא
עדיפי לאפוקי ממונא דאלימא
חזקת המחזיק כדאי׳ בדוכתי
טובא. ואם האיש הזה לא יאמין
לקול האות הראשון אולי יאמין
לקול האות האחרון. [i]

'Dream matters neither elevate nor lower,' according to the law one would not be obligated to afflict oneself because of such dreams. However, this dream 105R
that came with such astonishing content, and which testifies that everything his father told him in the dream came to pass, and he suffered difficult things for ignoring his father's words—I do not know how to involve myself in this matter. Although most dreams 110R
speak falsely, in this case he should be concerned for himself."[1] Thus far his words. Similarly, they said in Berakhot, first chapter, "Rabbi Nachman said: Even if the master of dreams tells a person that he will die tomorrow, he should not withhold himself from seek- 115R
ing mercy." And even though they said "Dream matters neither elevate nor lower," it seems to me they only meant that dreams are not superior enough to extract money from one who has the stronger claim of possession,[2] as is discussed in many places. And 120R
if this person does not believe the voice of the first sign, perhaps he will believe the voice of the latter sign.

הנה הנם היסורים הבאים על

Behold, these are the sufferings that come upon

[1] The author uses the Rashba's responsum to establish a nuanced approach to dreams: while most shouldn't be taken literally, dreams with particularly striking content or that have proven accurate deserve serious consideration as potential divine messages.

[2] This interpretation of the Talmudic statement "dream matters neither elevate nor lower" limits its application to financial disputes rather than dismissing dreams entirely. The author's explanation shows how rabbinic statements that seem to dismiss dreams can be reconciled with other traditions that take dreams seriously as divine communication.

[i] Cf. Book of Job 33:14-18 — The author directly references Elihu's statement from Job that God speaks to humans through dreams when they are sleeping deeply. This biblical passage is central to the author's argument that dreams serve as divine communication meant to warn people away from sin. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 10b — The author cites this talmudic passage to demonstrate that even when dreams predict death, one should still pray for divine mercy. This supports his argument that dreams should be taken seriously as potential divine warnings while still maintaining hope for divine intervention. | Cf. Responsa of the Rashba 483 — The author quotes Rabbi Solomon ben Adret (Rashba) to provide rabbinic precedent for taking certain dreams seriously, particularly those that have proven accurate in the past or contain especially striking content, despite the general rabbinic stance that dreams are not legally binding. | Cf. Zechariah 11:12 — The opening phrase about selling eternal life for shoes alludes to the prophet Zechariah's imagery of something valuable being sold for a paltry sum (thirty pieces of silver), which was later connected to Judas' betrayal of Jesus in Christian tradition. The author adapts this imagery to contrast eternal spiritual value against temporary material gain. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:12 — The phrase about not turning aside and going where the spirit directs clearly alludes to Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot, whose wheels moved directly without turning and went wherever the spirit directed them. The author uses this to describe divine providence and its agents that move according to God's will.

האדם לכפרת אשמה בהדרגה.
מעיקרא יאונה אליו מיחושים
ומכאובים בלי קדחת כמו מיחוש
ראש או לב או כבדות בשאר
אבריו. אך עדיין כחו יפה
בעצמותיו וזהו בהוכח במכאוב
על משכבו. ברם רוב עצמיו
איתן.[i] וגם שאחזו ויתק פי׳
חלשה כדאמרי׳ בגיטין פ״ז האי
מאן דשתי טיליא חיורא פי׳ יין
רע לבן אחזתו ויתק.[ii] עם כל זה
עדיין הוא בתקפו. (ומאן דחליש
יומא קמא לא ליגלי כי היכי
דלא ליתרע מזליה. וכן היה
עושה רבא במס׳ ברכות[iii] ויזהר
האדם בכל מעשיו דלא ליתרע
מזליה דאמרי׳ במס׳ כריתות
פ״ק. האי מאן דבעי למידע אי
מסיק ליה שתא אי לא ליתלי
שרגא בהדי עשרה יומי דבין
ריש שתא ליומא דכפורי בביתא
דלא נשיב זיקא בגויה אי משיך
נהוריה לידע דמסיק ליה שתא.
מאן דבעי למעבד עסקא ובעי
למידע עסקיה אי מצלח אי לא
לירבי תרנגולתא אי שמין שפיר
לידע דמצלח עסקיה. האי מאן
דבעי למיפק לאורחא ובעי
למידע אי הדר לביתיה או לא
ניקום בביתא דחברא אי חזו

a person gradually as atonement for guilt.[1] At first, he experiences discomforts and pains without fever,[A] such as headache, heart pain, or heaviness in his other limbs. Yet his strength remains intact in his bones, as it is written, "He is chastened with pain upon his bed, but the multitude of his bones are firm." Even if he is seized with weakness, as we say in Gittin chapter 7, "One who drinks poor white wine, it seizes him with weakness," nevertheless he still maintains his vigor.

(And one who falls ill on the first day should not reveal it, so that his mazal [fortune] will not be harmed. This was Rava's practice, as mentioned in Tractate Berakhot. A person should be careful in all his actions not to damage his mazal,[2] as we say in Tractate Kritot, chapter 1: "One who wishes to know if he will complete the year successfully should light a lamp during the ten days between the New Year and the Day of Atonement in a room where no wind blows; if the light extends well, he will know that he will complete the year successfully. One who wishes to engage in business and wants to know if his business will prosper should raise a chicken; if it grows fat, he will know his business will prosper. One who wishes to go on a journey and wants to know if he will return home should stand in the house of his friend; if they see the shadow of a shadow, he will know that he will return, and if they do not see the shadow of a shadow, he will know that he will not return home." The Talmud concludes there:

[A] Or: "Initially, discomforts and pains without fever befall him" — This alternative translation preserves the passive voice of the Hebrew phrase 'יאונה אליו' (befall him) rather than making it active. This might better reflect the author's view that these sufferings come upon a person from an external source (God) rather than arising from within.

[1] The author presents a theology of suffering where illness serves as divine correction rather than random misfortune. This progressive model of illness as spiritual purification is central to the book's approach to end-of-life care.

[2] The concept of 'mazal' here refers to one's spiritual fortune or destiny. The parenthetical section explores the relationship between psychological state (worry, fear) and spiritual wellbeing, suggesting that certain divination practices can actually harm one's spiritual state rather than protect it.

[i] This is a reference to Job 33:19, which discusses divine chastisement through physical suffering. The author is quoting scripture to establish that the initial stages of illness still leave one's fundamental strength intact.

[ii] The reference to 'poor white wine' comes from Talmudic medicine, where certain foods and drinks were believed to affect health in specific ways. Here, the author uses this example to illustrate a minor ailment that doesn't fully incapacitate a person.

[iii] This parenthetical section refers to Talmudic practices regarding illness and fortune. The belief was that revealing illness on the first day could damage one's mazal (spiritual fortune). The section contains several folk practices and omens that the author ultimately recommends against.

בבואה דבבואה נידע דהדר ואי
לא חזי בבואה דבבואה נידע
דלא הדר לביתיה. ומסיק התם
ולאו מילתא היא לא לעביד
הכי דילמא חזי סימנא בישא
ומצער נפשיה ומתרע מזליה.
הנה כי הפחד והצער והדאגה
מריעים כח המזל. ובפ׳ חלק על
מניין לקובלנא מן התורה פרש״י
כשאדם מודיע צערו לאחר צריך
לומר לא תבא זאת לך כמו
שבאה אלי כי קשה הוא לשמוע
שפעמים חוזרת עליו והמקפיד
על זה אין בו משום ניחוש. לשון
אחר נגד מתרגמינן קבל כאדם
שאומר לחבירו לא בנגדו אני
אומר עוד פרש״י על מחשבה
מועלת אפי׳ לדברו תורה דאגת
האדם על מזונותיו מהניא לשכח
תלמודו). ואם מיחושים אלו
לא ישוו לו להשיבו גם כן לא
יתנוהו השב רוחו רק נוסף עליו
קדחת קלה וכל אוכל תתעב
נפשו וזהו וזהמתו חייתו לחם
ונפשו מאכל תאוה.[i] והאי אישתא
מעלי לנפשא כתרייקא לגופא.
ואם עדיין לא שב עד המכהו
יגורהו בחרם דאשא דגרמי
המשחתת מראה בשרו. וזהו יכל
בשרו מרואי ושופו עצמותיו לא
רואו.[ii] והא אישתא צמירתא
בשעת הסכנה דמיא בדאמרי׳
בפסחים פ״ב. ואם עדיין מקשה
לבו ברעה נתוסף עליו חולי
סערת חושות וגוברים עליו
הליחות ובפרט הליחה לבנה
ונמצא עומד בין החיים ובין

"But this is not a reliable matter; one should not do this, lest he see a bad sign, cause himself distress, and damage his mazal." Thus, fear, distress, and worry harm one's fortune. And in chapter Helek, regarding the source for complainers in the Torah, Rashi explains: "When a person informs another of his troubles, he should say, 'May this not come upon you as it has come upon me,' for it is difficult to hear about troubles, as sometimes they return upon the listener, and one who is particular about this is not guilty of superstitious practice. Another interpretation: 'against' is translated as 'complain,' like a person who says to his friend, 'I am not speaking against him.'" Rashi further comments that worry affects even one's Torah study: "A person's anxiety about his livelihood causes him to forget his learning.") 155R 160R 165R 170R

If these discomforts do not suffice to return him [to the right path], nor allow him to regain his composure, a mild fever is added, and his soul abhors all food. This is the meaning of "his soul abhors bread, and his appetite dainty food." This fever benefits the soul like an antidote benefits the body.[A] And if he still does not return to the One who smites him, he is surrounded by a fire of the bones[B] that destroys the appearance of his flesh. This is the meaning of "his flesh is consumed away that it cannot be seen, and his bones that were not seen stick out." This burning fever resembles a time of danger, as we say in Pesachim, chapter 2. And if he still hardens his heart in wickedness, the illness intensifies with a storm of sensations, as the humors overpower him, especially the white phlegm, and he stands between life and death. This is the meaning of "his soul draws near to the pit, and his life to those who bring death." Even in this state, when he is at the crushing point of his soul,[1] if there is for him an interceding angel, 175R 180R 185R 190R

[A] Or: "This fever is beneficial to the soul as theriac is to the body" — The term 'תרייקא' (triaca/theriac) refers specifically to a historical medicinal compound used as an antidote to poisons. Using the specific historical term might better convey the medical understanding of the period.

[B] Or: "And if he still does not repent to the One who strikes him, he will be encircled by a burning heat in his bones" — This alternative clarifies that 'שב' here means 'repent' rather than simply 'return,' capturing the religious dimension of the text. It also translates the Aramaic phrase 'חרם דאשא דגרמי' more explicitly as referring to the burning sensation in the bones during high fever.

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'דכדוכה של נפש' (crushing of the soul) conveys the extreme spiritual and

[i] This is a reference to Job 33:20, continuing the scriptural framework that structures this entire discussion of progressive illness.

[ii] This quotes Job 33:21, describing the wasting away of flesh during severe illness, as the author continues to use Job's description of suffering as a framework for his explanation.

המתים. וזהו ותקרב לשחת נפשו וחיתו לממיתים[i] ואף גם זאת בהיותו עד דכדוכה של נפש. אם יש עליו מלאך מליץ אחד מני אלף ירפא וישוב לימי עלמיו[ii] ואם יעתר אל אלוה ירצהו וישעו יתן לו. כדאמרי׳ במס׳ ע״א פ״ד כי היסורים הם נאמנים בשבועתן שלא ילכו אלא ביום פלוני ובשעה פלונית וע״י פלוני וע״י סם פלוני.[iii] כל אלו הסבות מהפך הקב״ה על מי שאינו שם אורחותיו בעוה״ז כדי לפטור נפשו מעבור בשחת שהוא הגיהנם וחיתו שהיא הנשמה החיה באור תראה. הן כל אלה יפעל אל פעמים שלש עם גבר[iv] כדי להשיב נפשו מני שחת בעולם הנשמות לאור באור החיים בעולם התחייה:[v]

one of a thousand, he will be healed and return to the days of his youth; and if he entreats God, He will be favorable to him and grant him salvation.

As we say in Tractate Avodah Zarah, chapter 4, afflictions are faithful to their oath not to depart except on a specific day, at a specific hour, through a specific person, and by means of a specific remedy. All these circumstances are arranged by the Holy One, blessed be He, for one who does not set his ways right in this world, in order to exempt his soul from passing through the pit, which is Gehenna, and so that his life-force, which is the soul, may see the light.[1] Indeed, God does all these things two or three times with a man, to bring back his soul from the pit, to the world of souls, to be illuminated with the light of life in the world of resurrection.[2]

195R

200R

205R

מני קדם הורונו מקצת חכמינו ז״ל כי אין יסורין בלא עון. וגם

From ancient times, some of our Sages of blessed memory taught us[A] that there are no sufferings with-

[A] Or: "Since ancient times, some of our Sages of blessed memory have instructed us" — This alternate translation maintains the same meaning while using more formal language that better fits the scholarly tone of the text.

physical distress at this final stage of illness, yet the author emphasizes that divine mercy remains possible even at this point.

[1] Here the author reveals the ultimate purpose of divinely ordained suffering: it serves as a purification process that can spare the soul from more severe punishment after death and prepare it for spiritual elevation.

[2] The passage concludes with a reference to Jewish eschatology—the belief in the world of souls (olam haneshamot) as an intermediate state after death, and the eventual resurrection of the dead (techiyat hametim) when souls will be reunited with transformed bodies.

[i] This is a reference to Job 33:22, describing the nearness to death in the most severe stage of illness.

[ii] This quotes Job 33:23-25, describing the intercession of an angel and the possibility of recovery even from severe illness.

[iii] This Talmudic teaching personifies sufferings as having their own will and oath, emphasizing that illness has a divinely ordained purpose and timeframe.

[iv] This quotes Job 33:29, bringing the scriptural framework full circle by showing that God's purpose in sending affliction is ultimately redemptive—to save the soul from the pit of destruction.

[v] Cf. Book of Job — The author uses Job's description of divine chastisement through illness as a framework for explaining the progressive stages of suffering as spiritual correction | Cf. Talmud Tractate Gittin — The author cites Talmudic passages to support his understanding of illness symptoms and their significance | Cf. Talmud Tractate Berakhot — Used to support the author's teaching about protecting one's spiritual fortune (mazal) during illness | Cf. Talmud Tractate Kritot — The author uses this to explore the relationship between spiritual signs, psychological state, and one's fortune or destiny | Cf. Talmud Tractate Avodah Zarah — The author uses this to show that suffering has a divinely ordained purpose and timeline for spiritual correction | Cf. Talmud Tractate Pesachim — Supports the author's claim about the severity of certain illness stages in the progression of divine chastisement

דבשבת פרק ה׳ איתותב ר׳ אמי ורב אסי דאמרי הכי מ״מ ודאי לא חשיד קב״ה דעביד דינא בלא דינא. ע״כ אמרו במס׳ ברכות[i] אם רואה אדם שיסורין באים עליו יפשפש במעשיו וכל הרגיל בח״ר ד״ל[ii] פי׳ שהוא מתחרה עם יצרו ועושהו דל מונע חולאים מתוך ביתו כדאמרי׳ בברכות פ״ו וחשיך תקון נפשך וקדים תיקון נפשך וכל המזבח יצרו מכבד בוראו בשני עולמות. ואר״ל[iii] נאמר ברית במלח ונאמר ברית ביסורין וכו׳ ובסבתם האדם מרוצה לפני המקום כדגרסי׳ בספרי כ״ז שאדם שרוי בשלוה אין מתכפרין לו מעונותיו כלום והיוצא לדרך קודם קריאת הגב״ר[iv] דמו בראשו דמעיקרא חשוכה והדר נהורא. וע״י היסורין הוא מתרצה לפני המקום דכתיב כי את אשר יאהב ה׳ יוכיח. וג״כ סוף פ״ק דקדושין מעין זה. והיסורים הם חסד לאדם כדאי׳ בגמ׳ ובפסיקתא ובמכילתא אמר הקב״ה לדוד אם חיים אתה מבקש צפה ליסורים שנאמר דרך חיים תוכחת מוסר ופ״ק דתענית

out sin. And although in Shabbat chapter 5, Rabbi Ami and Rav Asi who said this were refuted, nevertheless, the Holy One, blessed be He, is certainly not suspected of executing judgment without justice. Therefore, they said in Tractate Berakhot: "If a person sees that sufferings are coming upon him, he should examine his deeds." And whoever regularly contends with his evil inclination and weakens it prevents illnesses from entering his house,[1] as we say in Berakhot chapter 6: "Stay up late to repair your soul and rise early to repair your soul."[A] And whoever sacrifices his evil inclination honors his Creator in two worlds.[2] 210R 215R 220R

And Rabbi Lakish said: "A covenant is mentioned regarding salt,[3] and a covenant is mentioned regarding sufferings,"[4] etc. And because of them [sufferings], a person becomes favored before God, as we learn in Sifrei: "As long as a person dwells in tranquility, none of his sins are atoned for." And one who sets out on a journey before the rooster's crow, his blood is on his own head, for initially there is darkness and afterward comes light. And through sufferings, he becomes favorable before God, as it is written: "For whom the Lord loves, He rebukes." And similarly at the end of the first chapter of Kiddushin something like this appears. 225R 230R 235R

And sufferings are kindness to a person, as is found in the Gemara, the Pesikta, and the Mekhilta: "The Holy One, blessed be He, said to David: 'If you

[A] Or: "staying up late and rising early to attend to your soul's rectification" — This Aramaic phrase from Berakhot would be more clearly expressed as a continuous thought about spiritual discipline at both ends of the day, rather than as two separate actions.

[1] This reflects the common rabbinic belief that spiritual discipline has direct effects on physical wellbeing, a theme central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness.

[2] The 'two worlds' refer to this world (olam hazeh) and the world to come (olam haba), reflecting the Jewish belief that proper spiritual conduct has consequences in both realms.

[3] This refers to Numbers 18:19 where God made an 'eternal covenant of salt' with Aaron and his descendants, using salt as a symbol of permanence and preservation.

[4] The parallel between salt and suffering suggests that just as salt preserves food, sufferings preserve the soul by purifying it from sin.

[i] Referring to the Talmudic tractate Berakhot, which contains teachings about daily prayers and blessings.

[ii] This is an abbreviation for 'contends with and weakens (his evil inclination),' literally 'challenges and makes poor.'

[iii] Abbreviation for 'And Rabbi Lakish said,' referring to Rabbi Shimon ben Lakish, a prominent sage of the Talmud.

[iv] Literally 'the calling of the rooster,' referring to dawn when roosters crow. This is mentioned in rabbinic literature as marking the transition from night to day.

אריב״ל[i] כל השמח ביסורין בעוה״ז מביא ישועה לעולם שנא׳ בהם עולם ונושע. ואמרו במס׳ ערכין פ״ג כל מי שעברו עליו מ׳ יום בלי יסורין קבל עולמו. ע״כ ר״א בר״ש[ii] (פ׳ הפועלים) היה אומר ליסורים באורתא אחי ורעי באו וכן רבי קבל עליו יסורין תליסר שנין ונחום איש גם זו בפרק סדר תעניות ובפ׳ חלק אמרי׳ דכשנפנה ר״ע ואמר לריב״ז חביבין יסורין שמכפרים עליך אמר להם סמכוני ואשמע דברי עקיבא בן יוסף תלמידי שאמר חביבין יסורין. והנה כרוזא קרי ופס ידא כתבא[iii] כי היסורים והחולאים והמיחושים הם הערה לחוטאים כי מוסר מלכים פתח מהם חרצובות רשע כדגרסי׳ בפ׳ חלק במנשה דכתיב ביה וידע מנשה כי ה׳ הוא האלהים ולגבר אשר דרכו נסתרה חקר אלוה ימציאוהו בעת כי ישביעוהו ממרורים. ויסורין דידיה מעיד להו חובא וחובא דאתקבור ליה לבניה. ר״ל אין אדם נוקף אצבעו מלמטה אא״כ מכריזין עליו מלמעלה. ויען כי כל הנגעים אדם רואה חוץ מנגעיו וגם אין חבוש מתיר עצמו אם ראה גבר דאשתפוך חמימותיה ומיום למחרתו אזיל ושפיל בגדר הדחויה ומאליו

seek life, expect sufferings,' as it is said: 'The way of life is through disciplinary correction.'" And in the first chapter of Ta'anit, Rabbi Joshua ben Levi said: "Whoever rejoices in sufferings in this world brings salvation to the world, as it is said: 'Through them the world is saved.'" 240R

And they said in Tractate Arakhin chapter 3: "Anyone who passes forty days without sufferings has received his [entire] world." Therefore, Rabbi Eleazar son of Rabbi Shimon (in the chapter Ha-Po'alim) would say to sufferings in the evening: "Come, my brothers and friends." And similarly, Rabbi [Judah the Prince][1] accepted sufferings upon himself for thirteen years, as did Nahum Ish Gam Zu,[2] as mentioned in the chapter on the Order of Fasts. And in the chapter Helek, it is said that when Rabbi Akiva turned and said to Rabbi Yohanan ben Zakkai: "Beloved are sufferings that atone for you," he said to them: "Support me so I may hear the words of Akiva ben Joseph my student, who said: 'Beloved are sufferings.'" 245R 250R 255R

And behold, the herald calls out and the hand writes that sufferings, illnesses, and pains are a warning to sinners, for "the discipline of kings opens for them the bonds of wickedness," as we learn in the chapter Helek about Manasseh, regarding whom it is written: "And Manasseh knew that the Lord is God." And for a man whose way is hidden, God will provide him with ways to find Him when He fills him with bitterness. And his sufferings testify to his sin, and the sin that will be buried with his children.[A] That is to say, a person does not stub his toe below unless it is announced about him from above. 260R 265R 270R

[A] Or: "His sufferings testify to his sins, and sins that will be buried with his children" — This Aramaic expression is difficult to render precisely, but the alternate translation better captures the idea that sins have consequences across generations.

[1] This refers to Rabbi Judah the Prince (Yehuda HaNasi), the compiler of the Mishnah, who according to the Talmud suffered for thirteen years and accepted his afflictions as spiritually beneficial.

[2] Nahum Ish Gam Zu was a Talmudic sage known for his extreme acceptance of suffering, always saying 'This too (gam zu) is for the best' about his misfortunes.

[i] Abbreviation for 'Rabbi Joshua ben Levi said,' another prominent Talmudic sage known for his teachings on suffering and redemption.

[ii] Abbreviation for 'Rabbi Eleazar son of Rabbi Shimon,' a Talmudic sage who was known to have endured great physical suffering.

[iii] An Aramaic expression from the Book of Daniel (5:5) alluding to divine judgment, literally 'the herald calls out and the hand writes.'

נופל ברויא דמנפשיה נפיל
למה לא נקיים עמו והלכת
בדרכיו לחזק ידים רפות
ולאמץ ברכים כושלות בהטיף
עליו מלתנו ומלבנו נוציא עמו
מלין באמור לו כי הנה אשרי
אנוש יוכיחנו אלוה אם מוסר
שדי אל ימאס כי הוא יכאיב
ויחבש ג״כ בשובו מדרכיו וחיה
וישלח ידו וירפאהו ויחלימהו
ויחייהו ויראהו אותו ואת נוהו
שאנן ושלו באורך ימים ושנות
חיים אם יבדוק חמצו והשאור
שבעסתו[i] לאור נשמתו ויתוודה
ויאנח עליהם ויקבל עליו לבל
ישוב עוד לבסלה:[ii]

And because a person sees all afflictions except his own, and also a prisoner cannot free himself, if one sees a man whose heat has poured out and from 275R
day to day he continues to weaken like a deteriorating fence that falls on its own like a drunkard who falls on his own,[A] why should we not fulfill with him "and you shall walk in His ways" to strengthen weak hands and to bolster failing knees by letting our words fall 280R
upon him and from our hearts bring forth words with him, saying to him: "Behold, happy is the man whom God corrects; if he does not reject the discipline of the Almighty. For He wounds, but He also binds up when he returns from his ways and lives. And 285R
He will send forth His hand and heal him, restore him, give him life, and show him and his dwelling peaceful and tranquil with length of days and years of life"—if he examines his leaven and the sourdough in his dough by the light of his soul,[1] confesses and 290R
sighs over them, and accepts upon himself never to return to folly again.

הלא ידענו אם לא שמענו פה
קדוש פום ממלל רברבן כקל
קרנא משרוקיתא[iii] ה״ה מעין
החכמה רשב״י[iv] בפרשה האזינו
על פסוק ימצאהו בארץ מדבר

Surely we know, if we have not heard, from a holy mouth speaking great things like the sound of horn and flute,[2] namely the fountain of wisdom, Rabbi 295R
Shimon bar Yochai, in Parashat Ha'azinu on the verse "He found him in a desert land, and in the

[A] Or: "like one who is intoxicated and falls of his own accord" — The Aramaic idiom is more elegantly expressed with this alternate wording, which preserves the metaphor while making it more accessible.

[1] This metaphor suggests using one's divine soul as an illuminating force to examine one's sins and imperfections, similar to how one would use light to search for leaven before Passover.

[2] The original uses Aramaic terminology ('karna mashrokita') found in the Book of Daniel, referring to musical instruments. This poetic description emphasizes the spiritual authority and eloquence of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai.

[i] A metaphor using leaven (חמץ) and sourdough (שאור) to represent sin and spiritual impurity that must be identified and removed. This imagery comes from Passover rituals of removing leaven.

[ii] Cf. Job 5:17 — The author uses this verse as scriptural proof that suffering should be viewed as divine correction rather than arbitrary punishment, reinforcing the theological framework of the entire passage. | Cf. Berakhot 5a — This direct quote from the Talmud establishes the rabbinic basis for interpreting suffering as a call to introspection and repentance, which is a central theme of the entire passage. | Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — The author uses this verse to support the claim that suffering and correction are necessary components of a spiritual life leading to salvation. | Cf. 2 Chronicles 33:13 — This biblical reference serves as a powerful example of how suffering can lead even the most sinful person (Manasseh was known for his idolatry) to spiritual recognition and repentance.

[iii] This is a poetic description using Aramaic phrases to describe Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai. It literally means 'a holy mouth speaking great things like the sound of horn and flute,' employing biblical language from Daniel 3:5 where musical instruments are mentioned.

[iv] H"H is an abbreviation for 'that is' (הלא הוא), and RSB"Y is an acronym for Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, the traditional author of the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism.

ובתוהו יליל ישימון יסובבנהו
יבוננהו וגו׳ דאמר בפירושו כי
אצטריך לאסיא חכים לאשתדלא
על החולה אין יכיל למיהב ליה
אסוותא דגופא יאות. ואי לא
ישתדל על אסוותא דנשמתא
ודא הוא אסיא דקב״ה ישתדל
עליה בהאי עלמא ובעלמא דאתי
והביא מעשה מספרא דההוא
טייעא יע״ש[i] גם בפ׳ בשלח דף
ס״א כ׳ בשעתא דבר נש שכיב
בבי מרעיה הא אתפס באטרוניא
דמלכא רישיה בקולרא רגלוהי
בטפסרא[ii] כמה חילין נטרין
ליה מהאי גיסא ומהאי גיסא
שיפוהי כולהו בדוחקא מגיחין
אלין באלין מיכלא אתעדי
מיניה. בההוא זמנא פקדין עליה
אפוטרופא למילף עליה זכות
קמי מלכא כדכתיב אם יש עליו
מלאך מליץ א׳ מני אלף. זכאה
חולקי׳ דבר נש דעייל עליה
ואוליף ליה אוריתא לשזבותיה
מן דינא ההי״ד אשרי משכיל
אל דל. ואיך יכיל לשובא ליה
למילף ליה אורחוי דחיי לאתבא
ליה קמי מאריה. ולכן נקרא
ביקור חולים כי צריך לזרזו
על ביקור ופשפוש ומשמוש
דרכיו ואורחותיו.[iii] ודא ודאי
תקילא ליה בכוליה תלמודיה
וכתוב בפ׳ פקודי שלצד
מערב בהיכלות הקדושה יש
אחד מאותם הנקראים חברים

waste howling wilderness; He encircled him, He instructed him, etc." who said in his commentary: "A wise physician must attend to the sick person; if he can provide healing for the body, that is appropriate. But if he does not strive for the healing of the soul, then it is the Holy One, blessed be He, who will attend to him in this world and in the world to come." And he brought a story from the book of that Arab merchant, see there. Also in Parashat Beshalach, page 61, it is written: "When a person lies in his sickness, he is seized by the King's officers, his head in a collar, his feet in stocks, many forces guard him from this side and that side, all his limbs are in distress, battling with one another, and food is removed from him. At that time, they appoint an advocate to teach merit for him before the King, as it is written: 'If there be for him an angel, an intercessor, one among a thousand.' Fortunate is the portion of the person who enters to him and teaches him Torah to save him from judgment, as it is written: 'Happy is he who considers the poor.' And how can one restore him, to teach him the ways of life, to return him before his Master? Therefore it is called 'visiting the sick' because one must urge him to examine and search his ways and paths.[1] And this is certainly as weighty for him as his entire learning." And it is written in Parashat Pekudei that on the western side in the holy chambers, there is one of those called "companions" who is appointed over those who attend to the sick,[2] that they should examine their deeds and return in repentance, as is expounded there and in other places. May the words of God make us hear this encouragement. And if to add days or hours to a life of little value, how many drinks did he consume

[1] The author presents a creative interpretation of the Hebrew term 'bikur cholim' (visiting the sick), connecting it to the root meaning 'examination' or 'investigation'. While not linguistically accurate, this wordplay reinforces the spiritual purpose of the visit: to encourage self-examination and repentance.

[2] The text refers to a mystical concept from the Zohar where spiritual entities ('companions') in the heavenly chambers are responsible for overseeing those who visit the sick on earth, creating a cosmic dimension to this mitzvah (religious obligation).

[i] This refers to a story in the Zohar about an Arab merchant ('tayya' in Aramaic). 'Y"Sh' is an abbreviation for 'see there' (יעויין שם), directing the reader to consult the original source.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar uses metaphors of physical restraint to describe the spiritual condition of the sick person. It describes them as 'seized by the King's officers, head in a collar, feet in stocks,' portraying illness as a form of divine judgment.

[iii] The author offers a creative etymology for the term 'bikur cholim' (visiting the sick), connecting it to the Hebrew word for 'examination' (bikur/investigation), suggesting that the visitor should encourage the sick person to examine their deeds. This is a homiletical rather than literal etymology.

340 הממונה על המשתדלים על
החולים שיפשפשו במעשיהם
וישובו בתשובה כנדרש שם
ונם במקומות אחרים אמרי
אל לנו ישמיע בזרוז זה ואם
345 להוסיף ימים או שעות בחיי
פורתא כמה משקין שתה מפסחא
ועד עצרתא[i] ולעשות אשרתא
לחיי שעה כמה רפואות תעלה
בעדניה. ומה לו לעשות להעביר
350 כתמי נשמתו ולהחיותה חיי עולם
בהלבינה כשלג ומה יהיה שכר
אסיא כדא כי ביום רעה ימלטהו
ה׳.[ii] פי׳ ביומא דשלטא ההיא
רעה למיסב נשמתיה ימלטהו
355 ה׳. ואחר שבשפתי פי חכם חן
ובלשון חכמים מרפא יעוררהו
לשוב בתשובה על הכלל ועל
הפרט[iii]

from Passover to Shavuot,[1] and to make a remedy for temporal life, how many medicines to heal in its time? What should one do to remove the stains of his soul and give it eternal life by making it white as snow? And what will be the reward for such a physician? "In the day of evil, the Lord will deliver him."[2] This means: on the day that evil rules to take his soul, the Lord will deliver him. And since "grace is in the lips of the wise, and healing is in the tongue of the wise," he will arouse him to return in repentance, both generally and specifically. 335R 340R

על הנשכחות ועל הגלויות
360 בהזכירו אליו ד׳ חלוקי כפרה
יורהו באורח מישור וילמדהו

Regarding forgotten and revealed sins, when one recalls the four categories of atonement, this text will guide him on the straight path and teach him un- 345R

[1]This refers to remedies or treatments taken during the period of counting the Omer (the 49 days between these festivals). The author is making a rhetorical contrast between the extensive efforts made for physical healing versus the often-neglected spiritual healing.

[2]This continues the quotation from Psalms 41:2 that began with 'Happy is he who considers the poor.' The author interprets this specifically as divine protection during one's own time of death or judgment, suggesting that those who properly visit the sick will receive mercy during their own final moments.

[i]This refers to the Jewish custom of counting the days between Passover and Shavuot (the counting of the Omer). The author is making a rhetorical point about how much effort people put into physical remedies during this period compared to spiritual ones.

[ii]This is a quote from Psalms 41:2, which continues the verse beginning with 'Happy is he who considers the poor' cited earlier. The author interprets 'the day of evil' specifically as the day of death when divine judgment occurs.

[iii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Ha'azinu — The Zohar is used here to establish the primary theological framework that proper medical care requires attention to both physical and spiritual healing. This reference provides authoritative backing for the book's central premise. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — This extended Zohar reference portrays illness as a form of divine judgment and the sick person as spiritually imprisoned. It establishes the critical importance of those who visit and teach Torah to the sick as their spiritual advocates before the divine court. | Cf. Psalms 41:2 — This biblical verse is used to support the religious obligation of visiting the sick, suggesting that the 'poor' in this context refers to the ill person who is impoverished in health and requires spiritual guidance. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — This reference establishes a cosmic dimension to visiting the sick, suggesting that there are heavenly appointees who oversee this mitzvah, particularly ensuring that visitors encourage the sick to examine their deeds and repent. | Cf. Psalms 41:2 — This verse is interpreted to mean that one who properly attends to the sick will be delivered by God on their own day of judgment or death, establishing a spiritual reciprocity for this mitzvah. | Cf. Proverbs 12:18 — This reference supports the idea that the wise words of those visiting the sick have healing power, connecting physical recovery with spiritual guidance through speech.

דעת תבונות איך יחשוב ביסורים
הבאים עליו להיות שברו על
ה׳ אלהיו דניחא להו לצדיקיא
365 לתברא גרמייהו ולאתחברא
תבירו על תבירו וכולא על ה׳
אלהיו כד״א כי עליך הורגנו
כל היום. כי עליך נשאתי חרפה
כדאי׳ בפ׳ ויקהל דף קצ״ח
370 ובפ׳ תרומה דף קנ״ט יען כי עור
האדם נתהוה מעור הנחש חלף
כתנות אור שהיו לו וגם בשר
אדם הוא חלקו ובשר מבשרו
כדדרשו על פסוק הכסיל שהוא
375 ס״מ שבעת במרום המריא ומרד
באדונו חובק את ידיו ואוכל את
בשרו ומדידיה קא אכיל. א״כ
במירוק גוף האדם בזה נחלשים
כחות החצונים ע״ד עת אשר שלט
380 האדם באדם לרע לו יעויין פי׳
פ׳ זה בזהר פ׳ שלח דף קע״ב
ע״ב ואמרו שם דלאו חידו הוא
למ״ה כד קטיל בר נש אלא אחזי
גרמיה בחידו למעבד רעותיה
385 דקב״ה דכתיב רוח שערה עושה
דברו ובהתחלש כח החצונים ע״י
יסורי בני אדם בזה מתמתקים
ג״כ הדינים קדושים וחוזרים אל
נרתקן למעלה להתבסם. ובזה
390 נמצא מקריב גופו קרבן לה׳
כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ נח דף ס״א ע״א
ובר נש דאיהו זכאה הוא קרבנא
ממש לכפרא ומזה ג״כ בסוף פ׳
פקודי. ופ׳ תולדות כתב. כד
395 אתרע גופא נשמתא שלטא ולבן
צדיק יבחן. ובחיר שבאבות בעא
רחמי ואתא חולשא. וזהו וקוי

derstanding about how to view the sufferings that come upon him, placing his hope in the Lord his God. For it is pleasing to the righteous to break themselves[A] and to join brokenness upon brokenness,[1] with everything directed toward the Lord their 350R
God, as it is written: "For Your sake we are killed all day long" and "For Your sake I have borne reproach," as explained in Parashat Vayakhel page 198 and Parashat Terumah page 159.

This is because human skin was formed from the 355R
skin of the serpent in place of the garments of light that humans originally possessed. Even human flesh is the serpent's portion and flesh of its flesh, as they interpreted regarding the verse about "the fool" who is Samael—when he was still in heaven, he rebelled 360R
against his master, folding his arms and consuming his own flesh.[B]

Therefore, when the human body is purified through suffering, the powers of the external forces are weakened, as the verse states: "a time when man 365R
rules over man to his hurt." See the explanation of this verse in the Zohar, Parashat Shelach page 172b, where they said that the Angel of Death does not rejoice when he kills a person,[2] but rather appears joyful in order to fulfill the will of the Holy One, 370R
Blessed be He, as it is written: "the stormy wind fulfilling His word."

As the external forces are weakened through human suffering, the holy judgments are also sweetened[3] and return to their sheaths above to be 375R
fragrant. In this way, a person offers his body as a sacrifice to God, as we say in Parashat Noah page 61a: "A righteous person is literally a sacrifice for atonement." This is also mentioned at the end of Parashat Pekudei and in Parashat Toldot, which 380R
states: "When the body is weakened, the soul

[A] Or: "the righteous willingly accept their own suffering" — This Aramaic phrase could be rendered more idiomatically to capture the concept that righteous individuals willingly accept suffering rather than the more literal 'breaking themselves.'

[B] Or: "he eats from what is his own" — This Aramaic phrase is more literally translated in the alternate version, which preserves the wordplay in the original that suggests Samael ultimately harms himself through his rebellion.

[1] This poetic phrase ("לאתחברא תבירו על תבירו" in the original) expresses how the righteous accept and even embrace successive afflictions as spiritually beneficial.

[2] The Hebrew acronym "מ״ה" refers to the Angel of Death (Malach HaMavet). This passage explains that even when executing divine judgment, the Angel of Death only appears joyful as part of fulfilling divine will, not out of actual pleasure in human suffering.

[3] In Kabbalistic terminology, "sweetening the judgments" (המתקת הדינים) refers to the process of transforming severe divine judgments into mercy or more balanced justice through spiritual actions.

ה׳ יחליפו כח שגם כי צדיקים
בעלי תורה הם תשושי כחות
400 גופניות זהו לפי שמחליפין כח
שהיה ראוי לגוף ונותנים אותו
לנשמה ועל כן התורה נקראת
תושיה שמתשת כחות יצר הרע
שהם כחות חומריות ועקר מזון
405 עוסקי בתורה לשמה הוא לשובע
נפשם ליהנות מרוחניות הקדוש
המתעלם ומתלבש בפת בגם
וביין משתיהם באופן כי הנפש
ניזונית מהעקר והגוף מהתמצית
410 מלבד שמזון החכמים נשפע להם
ממקום גבוה מן השמים והוא
זן הנפש בעצם והגוף במקרה
כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ בשלח ובשאר
מקומות מהזהר. על כן קוי ה׳
415 בכח מזונם זה יעלו אבר בנשרים
אחר מיתתם ילכו ולא ייעפו
ממלאכי חבלה יען כי רצו בעה״ז
לעשות רצון קונם ולא ייעפו
מכחות חומריות כי הכניעום
420 בחייהם לעבודת יוצרם. ובזה
זוכה כל צדיק למדור בפני
עצמו כפי זכות מעשיו כדאי׳
[i] במדרש רות דף ל״ג ע״א

dominates,"[A] and therefore "the righteous one is tested." Even the chosen one among the Patriarchs [Jacob] requested mercy and became weakened.

This is the meaning of "those who hope in the 385R
Lord shall renew their strength"—even though righteous Torah scholars have weakened bodily powers, this is because they exchange the strength that should have gone to the body and give it to the soul. This is why the Torah is called "tushiyah" 390R
(wisdom/substance) because it weakens (matesheth) the powers of the evil inclination, which are material powers.

The primary nourishment for those who engage in Torah study for its own sake is to satisfy their souls, 395R
to enjoy the holy spirituality that is concealed and clothed in their bread and in the wine they drink, such that the soul is nourished by the essence while the body is nourished by the residue. Additionally, the nourishment of the wise flows to them from a high 400R
place in heaven, which primarily feeds the soul and the body only incidentally, as explained in Parashat Beshalach and other places in the Zohar.

Therefore, those who hope in the Lord, through the power of this nourishment, "will soar on wings 405R
like eagles"[1] after their death. They will go and not grow weary from the angels of destruction, because they desired in this world to fulfill the will of their Creator. They will not tire from material powers, for they subdued these in their lifetime for the service 410R
of their Creator. In this way, each righteous person merits their own dwelling place according to the merit of their deeds, as stated in the Midrash Ruth, page 33a.

[A] Or: "When the body is broken down, the soul gains supremacy" — This alternative translation more strongly conveys the power dynamic between body and soul that is central to the text's mystical teaching about suffering.

[1] This is a reference to Isaiah 40:31, which the author interprets as referring to the souls of the righteous after death, suggesting they will have spiritual strength to overcome the angels of destruction they encounter.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel — The text cites this passage of the Zohar to support its claim that human skin is derived from the serpent's nature, replacing the original spiritual garments of light. | Cf. Zohar, Shelach — This reference explains the paradoxical nature of the Angel of Death, who appears joyful when fulfilling divine judgment but doesn't actually rejoice in human death. | Cf. Zohar, Noah — This source supports the concept that a righteous person's suffering serves as a sacrifice for atonement, much like temple offerings in earlier times. | Cf. Isaiah 40:31 — The author reinterprets this well-known verse to explain how the physical weakness of Torah scholars is actually a spiritual exchange, where bodily strength is transferred to strengthen the soul. | Cf. Midrash Ruth — This reference supports the teaching that each righteous person receives an individual dwelling place in the afterlife based on their specific deeds and merits.

ממעשה דרבי[i] ושם אמרו כי
425 משיבין לכסיל שאומר שרוצה
לראות חביריו בכבודם בעולם
הנשמות ואומרים לו שוטה
שבעולם מצווין אנו מפי הגבורה
שלא יעמדו רשעים בצד צדיקים
430 ולא צדיקים בצד רשעים ולא
טמאים בצד טהורים וכו׳ ויש
מקשט ומותיב ביתיה שבגן עדן
בשעה קלה כמעשה דיוקים
בן צרורת.[ii] ודברי תשובה
435 של ש״מ[iii] בכתובין וכמסורין
למעלה דמו ואינו צריך לומר
כתובו יען כי אלהינו מרחם
חושב מחשבות טובות עליו
לתת לו אחרית ותקוה טובה
440 לבל תטרף דעתו ונשמתו ביד
מלאכים אכזרים. ועוד כי אין
אדם משטה עצמו מעשות תשובה
בכל לבו בשעת מיתה כל קבל די
רוח יתירא ביה אז כדכתיב תוסף
445 רוחם יגועון[iv] וטובה מרדות
אחת בלבו של אדם יותר ממאה
מלקיות. על כן מיום שעמדתי
על דעתי רעיוני יבהלוני וסעיפי

From the story of Rabbi [Judah the Prince], where 415R
they said that we respond to the fool[A] who says he
wants to see his friends in their glory in the world
of souls,[1] saying to him: "Fool! In the world [to
come] we are commanded by the Almighty that the
wicked shall not stand beside the righteous, nor 420R
the righteous beside the wicked,[2] nor the impure
beside the pure," etc. And there are those who
adorn and prepare their dwelling in the Garden of
Eden in a brief moment, like the story of Yokim
of Tzeroroth.[B] And the words of repentance of a 425R
dying person are considered as if they were written
and delivered above,[C] and he need not say "write
them down," because our merciful God thinks good
thoughts about him, to give him a future and a good
hope, so that his mind will not be distracted and 430R
his soul [delivered] into the hands of cruel angels.
Moreover, a person does not deceive himself about
doing complete repentance in his heart at the time of
death, when an additional spirit is within him, as it
is written "You take away their breath, they expire" 435R
(Psalm 104:29), and a single self-admonishment in a
person's heart is better than a hundred lashes.[3]

Therefore, from the day I gained understanding,
my thoughts have troubled me and my thoughts

[A] Or: "From the story of Rabbi [Judah HaNasi], where they said that we answer the fool" — The alternate translation uses 'HaNasi' which is more commonly used in English scholarship to refer to Rabbi Judah the Prince, and uses 'answer' instead of 'respond' which is slightly more direct.

[B] Or: "And there are those who adorn and establish their home in the Garden of Eden in a brief moment, as in the story of Yakum ben Tzerorot" — The alternative offers a different transliteration of the name (Yakum instead of Yokim) which may be more accurate to the original pronunciation, and uses 'establish' for 'motiv' which might better capture the sense of setting up residence.

[C] Or: "And the words of repentance of a shechiv mera (deathly ill person) are considered as if they were written and transmitted above" — The alternate includes the technical term 'shechiv mera' which is the rabbinic legal term for a person who is deathly ill, and uses 'transmitted' for 'mesurin' which might be more precise in this context.

[1] The Hebrew 'olam haneshamot' refers to the spiritual realm where souls reside after death, an important concept in Jewish mystical teachings about the afterlife.

[2] This reflects the Jewish theological concept of the separation of the righteous and wicked in the afterlife, based on biblical and rabbinic sources.

[3] This is a rabbinic saying emphasizing the superior value of internal repentance over external punishment.

[i] This refers to a story about Rabbi Judah the Prince (Rabbi Yehuda HaNasi), who compiled the Mishnah around 200 CE. The text is drawing on rabbinic traditions about his teachings.

[ii] This appears to reference a rabbinic story about Yokim (or Yakum) ben Tzerorot who earned his place in the World to Come through a single meritorious action. The text uses this as evidence that one can prepare one's eternal dwelling even in a brief moment.

[iii] The abbreviation ש״מ stands for 'shechiv mera', a halakhic term for a person who is deathly ill, whose legal status differs from both a healthy person and a deceased person.

[iv] This is a quote from Psalm 104:29: "You take away their breath, they expire." The author is using this verse to support his point about spiritual awareness at the time of death.

ישיבוני אי שמים על זאת ישתומם
כל חכם ונקטה נפשי בחיי למה
יגע שביב אשנו וידעך נרנו
ח״ו[i] כמו באישון חשך ולא תופע
עליו נהורא דאורייתא. וכיון
שכל מתחיל כלה וכל אפיא
שוין וצל ימינו עלי ארץ למה
אחריתנו לא יסגא מאד בתורת
אור ווי לן דמייתינן כמות נבל.
בלתי יחידי סגולות מתי מספר
במענו למעוטם בטלים אשר עמם
עוז ותושיה כי פקודתם שמרה
רוחם בסדר מליהם בעת וזמן
שלא הושם בסד רגלם ואם ח״ו
שוט יחלה וימית פתאום והיה
בעם ככהן ובשרו עליו יכאב
ונפשו עליו תאבל ולמה האיש
החי דדמי למלאכא לא יתן אל
לבו בעודו באבו קודם בא יום
המהומה כי תשתרש בכל קצותיו
כל המחלה הלואי דלא לוסיף
עלה וכל היום הולך לאחור ולא
לפנים. וחילק ובילק אכלי ליה
להיותו צופה ומביט מתחלת
המחשבה סוף המעשה בהשאיר
לנפשו אחריו ברכה. וכ״ש אם
יזכה לו ולאחרים עמו ויעלה גם
עלה להמנות עם מצדיקי הרבים
המאירים ככוכבים[ii] בעשות חסד
של אמת עם החיים והמתים וינהר
נהוריה כשרגא בתוך קהל ועדה
במתיבתא דרקיעא בהעלותו על
ספר חקה דברי יחוד וטהרה
וקדושה.[iii] ומילין לצד עילאה
להאמר בכל שעה קמי באישא
קודם דיתני בעוקצין תליסר
מתיבאתא מעוקצי תחלואי
המרה המחלה והממיתה לשזבינן

have answered me: "Woe heavens!" At this every wise person would be astonished. My soul has loathed my life—why should the spark of our fire labor and our light be extinguished, heaven forbid, as if in the blackest darkness, with no light of Torah shining upon it? And since everything that begins ends, and all faces are equal, and our days are like a shadow on the earth, why should our end not greatly increase in the Torah of light? Woe to us who die like a fool, except for a few precious individuals of limited number—so few they are considered nullified—who possess strength and wisdom, for their appointed duty preserved their spirit through their ordered words at a time when their feet were not placed in stocks. And if, heaven forbid, a scourge should make one ill and suddenly kill, and it shall be the same for people and priests, his flesh shall suffer and his soul shall mourn. Why should the living person, who resembles an angel, not take to heart while still in his prime, before the day of confusion comes, that every disease will take root in all his extremities? If only it would not increase further, as each day he goes backward, not forward. 440R 445R 450R 455R 460R

Destruction and ruin consume him when he could be looking ahead from the beginning of thought to the end of action, leaving a blessing for his soul after him. And how much more so if he merits [this] for himself and for others with him, and also ascends to be counted among those who make the multitudes righteous, who shine like stars by performing true kindness with the living and the d[1]ead. And his light will shine like a lamp within the congregation and assembly in the heavenly academy, by committing to writing the laws of unification, purification, and sanctification. And words directed upward to be said at every hour before the evil one,[2] before he teaches thirteen academies about the stings of bitter disease 465R 470R 475R

[1]The Hebrew 'chesed shel emet' (true kindness) is often used specifically for kindness shown to the dead, as they cannot repay the favor—making it the purest form of kindness.

[2]This may refer to the Angel of Death or evil forces that might interfere with proper preparation for death.

[i]An abbreviation for 'chas v'shalom' (Heaven forbid), a common expression used when mentioning something negative or undesirable.

[ii]This is an allusion to Daniel 12:3: "Those who lead many to righteousness will shine like the stars forever and ever." The author is describing the merit of helping others prepare properly for death.

[iii]The author appears to be describing the merit of recording sacred teachings about spiritual unity, purity, and holiness—which is precisely what his book Ma'avar Yabok aims to do. This is a self-reference to the purpose of his work.

רחמנא. ואי סלקא לאיגמר שרותיה בכנפיך:[i][ii]

and sickness that kills[1]—may the Merciful One save us. And if it succeeds in completing its beginning under your wings.[A] 480R

ואמרתי אני אל לבי מה לך נרדם טוב הדבר אשר חשבת הנה ה׳ יצא לפניך להעלות זה על לבך למה תרפינה ידיך צא ועשה בן וקריינא דאגרתא איהו ליהוי פרונקא[iii] לכה נא שמעה בקולי איעצך. כי תדמה לכרם במדבר דחביב כדאמרי׳ במס׳ ר״ה פ״ק[iv] ושים על לבך מה שאמרו במדרש משלי א״ר אבין בר כהנא אם חשבת לעשות מצוה ולא עשית טוב לך ליתן זמם על פיך ולא לפסוק. עוד שם במקום אחר אמרו לעולם יעשה אדם עצמו קברניט היאך לעשות מצוה ובפרט בגמילות חסד כי הוא

And I said to myself: "Why are you slumbering?[B] Good is the thing you have contemplated. Behold, the Lord has gone before you to bring this to your heart. Why do your hands grow weak? Go and do so, for the bearer of the letter should be its deliverer. 485R Please listen to my voice; I will counsel you. For you are like a precious vineyard in the desert, as we say in the first chapter of Tractate Rosh Hashanah. And take to heart what they said in the Midrash Proverbs: Rabbi Abin bar Kahana said, 'If you 490R thought to perform a commandment but did not do it, it is better for you to place a muzzle on your mouth rather than to make a promise and not fulfill it.' And elsewhere they said, 'A person should always make himself like a ship's captain,[2] figuring 495R out how to perform a commandment, especially acts

[A] Or: "And if it is possible to complete its service under your protection" — This Aramaic phrase is difficult to translate precisely. The alternate offers 'service' for 'sheroteih' which might be more accurate than 'beginning', and interprets 'under your wings' as 'under your protection' which clarifies the metaphorical meaning.

[B] Or: "And I said to my heart: "Why are you dormant?" — This translation more directly reflects the Hebrew phrase 'אל לבי' (to my heart) and uses 'dormant' as an alternative to 'slumbering' that might better capture the sense of spiritual inactivity.

[1] The author uses vivid metaphorical language comparing disease to stinging insects and connects this to the talmudic tractate Uktzin (Stems/Stings), creating a wordplay that links physical suffering with spiritual teachings.

[2] The metaphor of a ship's captain (קברניט) suggests someone who takes initiative and navigates through challenges to achieve a worthy goal, particularly in relation to performing commandments.

[i] This Aramaic phrase uses the metaphor of protection 'under wings' which appears frequently in biblical and rabbinic literature, especially in reference to divine protection. Here it likely refers to divine assistance in completing the work.

[ii] Cf. Talmud, Berakhot 28b — The author alludes to a rabbinic story about someone who earned his place in the afterlife in a brief moment, using this as evidence that deathbed repentance can be effective. | Cf. Talmud, Shabbat 153a — The author draws on talmudic concepts about deathbed confessions and their efficacy, supporting his argument that one should prepare for death through proper spiritual activities. | Cf. Psalm 104:29 — The author uses this verse to support the idea that at death, an additional spiritual awareness comes to a person, making deathbed repentance more likely to be sincere. | Cf. Daniel 12:3 — The author draws on this biblical image to describe those who help others prepare for death properly as 'making the multitudes righteous' who will 'shine like stars'—connecting his work to this sacred biblical mission. | Cf. Zohar on the soul's journey after death — This entire passage mirrors Zoharic concerns with proper preparation for death and the soul's destiny afterward, suggesting the author is drawing on kabbalistic frameworks for understanding death and the afterlife.

[iii] This is an Aramaic expression meaning "the one who reads the letter should be its messenger," suggesting that the person who proposes an idea should be the one to implement it.

[iv] The author references the Talmudic teaching (Rosh Hashanah 4a) that a vineyard in the desert is especially precious because it is rare and difficult to maintain, using this as a metaphor for the spiritual value of his work.

מהעשרה דברים שנקראים חיים
וזוכים לחסות תחת צל כנפיו של
הקב״ה כדאמרי׳ במדרש רות
גדול כחן של גומלי חסדים שאין
חסין לא בצל הארץ וכו׳ רק
בצל כנפיו של הקב״ה ובפסיקתא
אמרי׳ אם נזדמן לחבירך יום
רעה ראה לעשות עמו חסד. ברם
ברגע כמימריה הדרי בי וחזרתו
לאחורי כי כליותי יסרוני
וסרעפי לבי בקרבי הוכיחוני
אוי לאזנים שכך שומעות סוב
לך על ימינך או על שמאלך
ואל תוסף דבר עוד בדבר הזה
ואפי׳ דבור אסור לך כי איך
ישתרר זעיר הזבובים קצוץ
הכנפים וכי הגון אתה ללמד
תורה וחצבי לנהרא כגני לייא
פן תהיה לבוז ולמשסה לכל
בעל דעת צלולה. דמעייל פילא
בקופא דמחטא[i] ומציץ מן חרכי
התבונה במאמרי התנא והאמורא
ודרשה והגדה וכל המרגיל אחר
סתרים לבקר יזקוף קועיה עליך
כחויא וינהום לנגדך הגם שאול
בנביאים[ii] מה זה לבן קיש קיש
קריא. הא בטעמא תליא מילתא
ומי הכנים שבור בין הנזירים.
דבר ידבר בשערים ומי הוא זה
השם עבים רכובו ומה כחו ומה
גבורתו ואנכי היודע ועד שכל
רוח אין בקרבו ולא בחל ולא
שרק ולא פרכוס וגם לא מעלה

of kindness, for it is among the ten things that are called “life”[1] and merit taking shelter under the wings of the Holy One, blessed be He.’ As we say in the Midrash Ruth, ‘Great is the power of those who perform acts of kindness, for they shelter not in the shadow of the earth, etc., but only under the wings of the Holy One, blessed be He.’ And in the Pesikta they say, ‘If your friend encounters a day of trouble, see that you perform kindness with him.’ 500R 505R

Yet in a moment, as quickly as it was said, I retracted and turned back, for my kidneys admonished me[2] and the thoughts of my heart within me rebuked me: ‘Woe to the ears that hear such things! Turn to your right or to your left and do not add another word in this matter. Even speech is forbidden to you! For how can a tiny fly with clipped wings lord it over others? Are you worthy to teach Torah? Drawing water from the river is like garden waste! Lest you become an object of contempt and plunder to anyone of clear mind—like one who tries to push an elephant through the eye of a needle! Peering through the cracks of understanding at the sayings of the Tannaim and Amoraim, at sermons and legends—anyone accustomed to investigating secrets will raise his voice against you like a serpent and roar at you: “Is Saul also among the prophets?[3] What is this to the son of Kish? Kish, kish” (a mere trifle). The matter depends on reasoning, and who has brought a drunkard among the Nazirites? He speaks at the gates, but who is this who makes the clouds his chariot, and what is his strength and his might? And I know and testify that there is no spirit within him—no eye makeup, no rouge, no adornment,[A] and 510R 515R 520R 525R

[A] Or: “neither cosmetics, nor paint, nor beautification” — This alternate translation uses more general terms for cosmetic enhancement that might be more accessible to modern readers, though the original translation more precisely captures the specific ancient beauty treatments referenced.

[1] This refers to a rabbinic list of things that provide or sustain life in both physical and spiritual senses, including Torah, rain, and acts of kindness.

[2] In biblical and rabbinic literature, the kidneys (כליות) are considered the seat of conscience and moral guidance, similar to how we might refer to the heart today.

[3] This biblical reference is used sarcastically to express how the author imagines critics would respond to his presumption in writing on religious matters—with surprise and derision at someone seemingly unqualified assuming the role of a spiritual authority.

[i] An Aramaic expression meaning “like one who tries to force an elephant through the eye of a needle,” used to describe an impossible task or someone attempting something far beyond their capabilities.

[ii] A biblical reference to 1 Samuel 10:11-12, used as an idiom expressing surprise when someone engages in an activity not typically associated with them. Here it represents the imagined mockery of others who would question the author’s qualifications.

חן וכללא דמילתא האי סיתומתא
לא קניא. עד כי נתרשלו ידי
וישבתי מרעיד תוהא ובוהא
בין חרד וירא בין אסור ושרי
ואין ולאו רפיא בידי ואוי לי
אם אומר ואוי לי אם לא אומר.
ואשתומם כשעה חדא ואוי לי
מיוצרי ואוי לי מיצרי:[i] [ii]

no charm. The principle of the matter is that this sealed barrel does not acquire ownership.'

Until my hands grew slack, and I sat trembling, confounded and bewildered, between fear and terror, between forbidden and permitted. Yes and no wavered in my hand, and woe to me if I speak, and woe to me if I do not speak. And I was astonished for about an hour, and woe to me because of my Creator, and woe to me because of my inclination."

בין דא לדא עיני לשמיא נטלית
ומנדעי יתוב עלי והנה רוח
גדולה וחזק מפרק הרי העצלות
ומשבר סלעי אבן נגף וצור
מכשול ויעירני כאיש אשר יעור
משנתו ונתן בקולו קול עוז
עלי.[iii] שמע נא נבער מדעת למה
יקחך לבך ולמה ישיאך יצרך
מלהכין בית מנוס לך ולאחרים
בני גילך עמך הלא ידעת כי מדה
טובה אינה חוזרת. וא״ר יוחנן
לר׳ יוסי בר חנינא בסנהדרין
פ״ג[iv] הואיל ועלית לא תרד ונדר
גדול נדרת לאלהי השמים. ועצה
שיש בה דבר ה׳ תקום לעולם
מהר ומשה כאשר דברת ותצרף
מחשבתך הטובה למעשה והשלך
על ה׳ יהבך והוא יגמור על ידך

Between these matters, I lifted my eyes to heaven and my understanding returned to me.[1] And behold, a great and powerful wind broke apart the mountains of laziness and shattered the rocks of stumbling and the stones of obstruction. It awakened me like a man who is roused from his sleep, and placed upon me a voice of strength. Listen now, you who lack understanding, why does your heart lead you astray, and why does your inclination persuade you against preparing a house of refuge[2] for yourself and for others of your generation with you? Do you not know that a good measure never returns empty? Rabbi Yochanan said to Rabbi Yossi bar Chanina in Sanhedrin chapter 3: "Since you have ascended, do not descend,"[3] and "You have made a great vow to the God of Heaven." Counsel that contains the word of God will stand forever. Hurry and act as you have spoken, joining your good thoughts

[1] This opening echoes Daniel 4:31-34, where King Nebuchadnezzar describes his restoration after a period of madness. The author uses this biblical allusion to frame his spiritual awakening.

[2] The 'house of refuge' refers to Ma'avar Yabok itself, which the author is being called to complete as a spiritual guide for others facing death and illness.

[3] This Talmudic principle suggests that once someone has achieved a certain spiritual level or undertaken a sacred task, they should not abandon it for something lesser.

[i] This phrase reflects the classic Jewish spiritual tension between divine calling ("my Creator") and the limitations of human nature ("my inclination"). The author expresses being caught between his sense of divine purpose and his own self-doubt.

[ii] Cf. Talmud, Tractate Rosh Hashanah — The author cites this source to support the idea that a vineyard in the desert is especially precious, using this as a metaphor for the spiritual value of his work despite its challenging context. | Cf. Midrash Proverbs — This reference establishes the religious importance of completing good intentions rather than merely contemplating them, which reflects the author's struggle with whether to undertake his writing project. | Cf. Midrash Ruth — The author uses this reference to establish the spiritual merit of acts of kindness (gemilut chasadim), particularly as they relate to helping the sick and dying, which is the central theme of Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. 1 Samuel 10:11-12 — This is used idiomatically to express how the author imagines others will react with surprise and mockery if he attempts to position himself as a religious authority despite his perceived unworthiness.

[iii] The text shifts here from Aramaic (with phrases like 'עיני לשמיא נטלית' and 'ומנדעי יתוב עלי') to Hebrew, creating a bilingual introduction that mirrors the style of Daniel 4:31, where the biblical text similarly shifts from Aramaic to Hebrew at a moment of spiritual awakening.

[iv] The abbreviation פ״ג stands for פרק ג, meaning 'chapter 3' of the Talmudic tractate Sanhedrin.

והכל לש״ש מותר ושרי.[i] ואפי׳
עבירה לשמה גדולה ורצויה
היא.[ii] והפוך בנבלתא ולא
תהפוך במילך[iii] דכל בר נש איתי
ליה זכותיה גו קופתיה.[iv] וכל
עוד שמעשה בני אדם בדבר
מצוה לא יגרום פירוד למטה
דרכו נכון אל אשר יהיה שמה
הרוח עליון מרום וקדוש ומלאכי
אלהים עולים ויורדים בו ועל
ידו ליחד אל איום. ואמרי׳
בספרי אביי אמר ואגודתו על
ארץ יסדה כשישראל שוין בעצה
א׳ מלמטה שמו הגדול משתבח
מלמעלה שנא׳ ויהי בישורון
מלך אימתי בהתאסף ראשי
עם ובן הוא אומר ואגודתו על
ארץ יסדה ולא כשהם עשויות
אגודות אגודות רשב״י אומר
משל לשתי ספינות קשורות
באוגנים וברשתות ובנו עליהם
פלטרין והעמידום על גביהם כל
זמן שהספינות קשורות פלטרין
קיימין פרשו הספינות אין
פלטרין קיימין ואמרו בילמדנו
הובא בילקוט דף רע״ח לא
תשימו אגודות אגודות ותהיו
חולקים אלו על אלו שלא
תשימו קרחה בכם כשם שעשה
קרח שחלק לישראל ועשאן

with action. Cast your burden upon the Lord, and
He will complete the work through you, and every-
thing for the sake of Heaven is permitted and al-
lowed. Even a transgression for the sake of Heaven 560R
is great and desirable.[1] Better to handle a carcass
than to go back on your word, for every person has
his merits in his basket. And as long as people's
actions are focused on matters of commandment,
this will not cause division below. Their path is 565R
correctly directed to where the lofty and holy Di-
vine Spirit will be, and God's angels ascend and de-
scend through it and by its means to unify the awe-
some God. And we say in the Sifrei: Abaye said,
"His bundle upon the earth He founded"[2] (Amos 570R
9:6)—when Israel is united in one counsel below, His
great name is praised above, as it is said, "He be-
came King in Jeshurun when the heads of the people
gathered" (Deuteronomy 33:5). And so it says, "His
bundle upon the earth He founded"—not when they 575R
are made into separate groups. Rabbi Shimon bar
Yochai says: It is like two ships tied together[3] with
ropes and nets, and they built palaces upon them
and established them above. As long as the ships
remain connected, the palaces stand; if the ships 580R
separate, the palaces cannot stand. And they said
in the Yelamdeinu, brought in Yalkut page 278: "Do
not form separate factions and be divided against
one another, so that you do not create a 'bald spot'
(division) among yourselves,[4] as Korah did when he 585R
divided Israel and made them into separate factions,

[1] This controversial statement refers to rare situations where an otherwise forbidden act might be permitted when done with pure intentions for a sacred purpose. In this context, it likely refers to the author overcoming his own sense of unworthiness to complete the book.

[2] This creative interpretation of Amos 9:6 transforms a verse about God's heavenly chambers into a teaching about communal unity. The interpretation appears in Midrash Tanchuma and other rabbinic sources.

[3] This parable attributed to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai illustrates how communal unity provides a foundation for spiritual achievements that would collapse if the community were divided.

[4] This wordplay connects Korah's name (קרח) with the term for baldness or division (קרחה), presenting him as one who created a division in the community that led to disaster.

[i] The abbreviation ש״ש stands for שם שמים (for the sake of Heaven), a fundamental concept in Jewish ethics indicating pure intention without personal gain.

[ii] This controversial concept of 'a transgression for the sake of Heaven' references the Talmudic principle derived from Judges 5:24 regarding Jael's deception of Sisera. It suggests that in extraordinary circumstances, actions normally forbidden might be permissible when done with pure intentions for a sacred purpose.

[iii] This Aramaic expression is a proverb meaning 'Turn over a carcass but do not go back on your word,' emphasizing that handling something ritually impure is preferable to breaking a commitment.

[iv] An Aramaic expression meaning 'every person has his merits in his basket,' suggesting that each individual has their own collection of good deeds and virtues.

אגודות אגודות ועשה קרחה
בישראל שנבלעו עמו בני אדם
הרבה.[i] ואם אהיה שיחה בפי
הבריות מוטב לי להקרא שוטה
כל ימי ולקיים מוצא שפתיך
ואם האדם יראה לעינים הלא
ה׳ יראה ללבב והוא יחקור
ויודע כוונתי הטובה הזאת
כי ממנו לא יפלא כל דבר
ויודע תעלומות לב. והאלהים
הוא יודע כי לא באתי ליטול
עטרה לעצמי ולמען ספר שמי
ח״ו.[ii] והנה מארץ שפל מקומי
אלא כתר תורה מונח ועומד וכל
הרוצה ליטול את השם בעבודת
שמים יטול ומאן דיהיר בעל
מום הוא ולא מתקבל בדאמרי׳
בבתרא ובסוטה ובמגילה.[iii] וכל
פטטיא דאורייתא טבין ואם לא
הוצק חן בשפתותי הלא חכמה
בראש הומיות תקרא מעצמה
שהיא אילת אהבים ויעלת חן
ואם אנכי איש נדהם ונרדם
והדבר אין בי וגם לא בינת
אדם לי הלא עולמתא שפירתא
דלית לה עיינין[iv] דאתקשטת
בקישוטין דילה הוות שדרת
לגבי דאיש פתי. ואמרה אמרו
להההוא פתי דיקרב הכא ואשתעי
בהדיה כדכתיב מי פתי יסור
הנה. ואמרו בחגיגה פ״ק מה
נטיעה פרה ורבה אף דברי
תורה פרין ורבין והקיצות היא
תשיחך ואגברו חמרא דאורייתא

creating a division in Israel that caused many people
to be swallowed up with him." And if I become a
topic of conversation among people, it is better for
me to be called a fool all my days and fulfill the
utterance of my lips. Though man sees the outward
appearance, does not the Lord see the heart? He
will search and know this good intention of mine,
for nothing is hidden from Him, and He knows the
secrets of the heart. And God knows that I have
not come to take a crown for myself or to spread
my name, God forbid. Indeed, from my lowly place,
the crown of Torah rests available,[1] and whoever
wishes to take the Name in the service of Heaven
may take it. One who is arrogant has a blemish and
is not accepted, as we say in Bava Batra, Sotah, and
Megillah. All chatter related to Torah is good, and
if grace has not been poured upon my lips, does not
wisdom call out at the head of the noisy streets by
itself? For it is a loving hind and a graceful doe. And
if I am a man confused and slumbering, and I have
no capacity or human understanding, is it not like
a beautiful maiden without eyes[2] who adorns herself
with her ornaments and sends a message to a simple
man saying, "Tell that simple man to come here and
converse with me," as it is written, "Whoever is sim-
ple, let him turn in here" (Proverbs 9:4). And they
said in Chagigah, first chapter: Just as a plant grows
and multiplies, so too the words of Torah are fruitful
and multiply. "When you awake, it shall talk with
you" (Proverbs 6:22). They strengthened the wine of
Torah for the children so they would speak words of
Torah. And if Aaron Berechia is like a donkey with
a saddle[3] in comparison, I will keep moving forward,
for it is his obligation to make himself like a donkey

[1] This refers to the rabbinic teaching in Pirkei Avot 4:13 that the crown of Torah is available to all who seek it, unlike other crowns (priesthood, kingship) that are restricted to certain lineages.

[2] This striking metaphor suggests that Torah wisdom possesses inherent beauty but requires human engagement and interpretation (the 'eyes') to be fully expressed and directed.

[3] The author's self-deprecation as a beast of burden for Torah recalls Moses' humility and the rabbinic value of making oneself a vessel for divine teaching rather than seeking personal glory.

[i] The text makes a wordplay on the name Korah (קרח) and the word 'baldness' or 'division' (קרחה), a pun found in rabbinic literature where Korah's rebellion is associated with causing a 'bald spot' or division in the community.

[ii] The abbreviation ח״ו stands for חס ושלום (God forbid), indicating the author's strong rejection of seeking personal fame.

[iii] References to three Talmudic tractates (Bava Batra, Sotah, and Megillah) where the principle that arrogance is a spiritual blemish is discussed.

[iv] An Aramaic phrase meaning 'a beautiful maiden without eyes,' likely alluding to Torah wisdom that is intrinsically beautiful but requires human interpretation and application to be fully expressed.

לדרדקי כי היכי דלימרו מילתא.
ואם אהרן ברכיה חמרא אוכפא
630 לגביה[i] אמוש וחובה עליו
לשום עצמו כחמור למשאוי
תורה וחמרא דימא לאורייתא
שרי[ii] ואם הוא סיכסא וכעניי
דצפרא דלית בהו ממשא תורת
635 ה׳ תמימה מחכימת פתי ותופע
עליו נהורא דעמה שרא: [iii]

carrying the burden of Torah. The donkey of the sea is permitted for Torah study. And if he is confused and like the morning clouds that have no substance, "The Torah of the Lord is perfect, making wise the simple" (Psalms 19:8), and may the light that dwells with Him shine upon him.[1]

על כן בעזר אל איום ונורא.
אני נפש נכאה ונלאה כרחל
נאלמה[iv] מהמון תמורות הזמן
640 הבוגד ועני ובואב וכל ימי עני
רעים זה שדעתו קצרה אללי
לי אללי[v] כי עונותי עשאוני
אשפה ורק אני נשארתי לבדי
עם נערי אתי מאסקופת העזר״ה
645 ולחוץ[vi] בעמידה שאין בה שום
סמיכה ותמיכה והוא גברא על
פלטר סמיך[vii] ותמיך ברחמי

Therefore, with the help of the awesome and fearsome God, I, a despondent and weary soul, silent like Rachel[2] before the tumult of treacherous times, poor and in pain—all the days of the poor are miserable—one whose understanding is limited. Woe to me! Woe to me! For my sins have made me like refuse, and I alone remain by myself, with only my servant accompanying me, from the threshold of the Temple courtyard and outward, standing without any support or assistance. That man depends on the Provider and is supported by heaven's mercy, for

[1] The passage concludes with a prayer that divine illumination will overcome the author's perceived inadequacies, reflecting the fundamental Jewish belief that Torah study itself provides enlightenment regardless of one's initial capabilities.

[2] This self-description uses biblical imagery to establish the author's emotional state. The Rachel reference creates a powerful connection to Jewish collective grief.

[i] Here the author refers to himself in the third person, calling himself 'a donkey with a saddle' as an extreme form of self-deprecation, a rhetorical device common in rabbinic literature.

[ii] The phrase 'חמרא דימא' (literally 'donkey of the sea') may refer to a sea creature (possibly a dolphin or sea lion) and is being used metaphorically to suggest that even someone with limited capacities can be 'permitted' or useful for Torah study.

[iii] Cf. Sanhedrin — The author references a Talmudic passage to support the principle that once one has begun a worthy endeavor, one should not abandon it. | Cf. Amos 9:6 — The verse about God's 'bundle upon earth' is interpreted as referring to the unity of Israel, suggesting that communal harmony is essential for divine presence. | Cf. Deuteronomy 33:5 — This verse about God becoming king when Israel's leaders gather is used to emphasize that divine glory is manifest when the community is united. | Cf. Korah narrative — Korah's rebellion is presented as a cautionary tale against causing division in the community, with severe consequences for those who create factions. | Cf. Proverbs 9:4 — This verse personifying wisdom calling to the simple is used to suggest that Torah wisdom seeks out even those who feel inadequate, offering them understanding. | Cf. Chagigah — The Talmudic passage comparing Torah to a growing plant emphasizes how Torah study produces continual growth and development in understanding. | Cf. Proverbs 6:22 — This verse suggesting that Torah speaks to one who awakes reinforces the idea that sincere Torah engagement results in ongoing inspiration and guidance. | Cf. Psalms 19:8 — This verse about Torah's perfection and its ability to make the simple wise is offered as a hopeful assurance that even those who feel inadequate can gain wisdom through Torah study.

[iv] The author compares himself to a silent Rachel, which may refer to the biblical Rachel or to the personification of the Jewish people in Jeremiah 31:15, where Rachel weeps for her children.

[v] This is a Hebrew expression of lament or woe, intensified by repetition.

[vi] "From the threshold of the Temple courtyard and outward"—a metaphorical expression indicating exclusion from sacred or privileged spaces. The term עזר״ה (with quotation marks in the original) refers specifically to the Temple courtyard.

[vii] An Aramaic expression meaning "that man depends on the Provider," with פלטר referring to God as the ultimate provider.

שמיא כי מאשפות ירים אביון
ושואג כארי ממצוקים זמני
מזעזוון בלהן. ועקן דעדו עלי
כידוע לכל באי שער עמי. ואסיא
רחוקא עינא עויר.[i] אני הוא
שמי הקטן שבחבורה הנה הוא
אנוש רמה וכאצבעתא בקירא
לסברא וטעמא.[ii] לאו נגר ולא
בר נגר אנא ולא ריבא ולא
בר ריבא[iii] ברם בריה קלה
דבטיל במיעוטא[iv] אהרן ברכיה
בכמה"ר[v] משה יצ"ו[vi] בכמה"ר
נחמיה איש מודינ"ה ז"ל נין
ונכד מצפירת תפארת ביתנו הם
אמי הזקנה החשובה והחכמה
מר"ת פיווריטה דמיתקריא
בת שבע[vii] אלמנת הגאון
במוהר"ר[viii] שלמה יעקב רפאל
בן הגאון ורופא מופלא בדורו
במהור"ר מרדכי ממודינ"ה
זצ"ל[ix] מקדמוני משפחות גרוש
צרפת[x] אשר הזקנה הנזכרת
אענדנה לעולם עטרות לראשי
כי היא ולא אחר עמה מיום צאתי
מרחם אמי גדלתני כבן וחייב
אני לה מורא וכבוד כאב ואם
וגם רב שבדרך חכמה הורתני
הגם דלא חכימא אנח ולא חוזאה

"He raises the poor from the dust"[1] and I roar like a lion from the straits of my frightening and terrifying times and troubles that have befallen me, as is known to all who enter the gates of my people. And "a distant physician leaves the eye blind." 640R

I am the least significant in the group, a mere mortal, like a worm, and like a finger in wax when it comes to reasoning and understanding. I am neither a carpenter nor the son of a carpenter, neither a scholar nor the son of a scholar, but rather an insignificant creature who is nullified by the majority—Aaron Berechia, son of the honorable Rabbi Moses[2] (may his Rock preserve him), son of the honorable Rabbi Nehemiah of Modena, of blessed memory, descendant of the ornament of our household's glory, my elderly, esteemed, and wise mother, Fiorita[3] (also called Bat-Sheva), widow of the brilliant Rabbi Solomon Jacob Raphael, son of the genius and extraordinary physician of his generation, Rabbi Mordecai of Modena, of blessed memory, from the early families exiled from France.[4] 645R 650R 655R

I will forever crown my head with the aforementioned elderly woman, for she, and no other with her, from the day I left my mother's womb, raised me like a son. I owe her reverence and honor as to a father and mother, and also as a teacher who instructed me in the way of wisdom, although I am neither wise nor a seer, and I have not fully learned or mastered, but 660R 665R

[1] A quotation from Psalm 113:7, expressing hope that God will elevate the author from his lowly state.
[2] This genealogical passage establishes the author's identity and lineage, which was important in rabbinic tradition to establish authority.
[3] The author gives special prominence to his grandmother who raised him, showing the importance of maternal lineage in his self-identity.
[4] This reference to the French expulsion establishes the author's family as having Sephardic origins, despite living in Italy.

[i] An Aramaic proverb meaning "a distant physician leaves the eye blind," suggesting that distant help is ineffective.
[ii] An Aramaic expression comparing his intellectual capacity to "a finger in wax," suggesting malleability or limited impact.
[iii] An Aramaic expression of humility: "I am neither a carpenter nor the son of a carpenter, neither a scholar nor the son of a scholar."
[iv] An Aramaic expression meaning "an insignificant creature who is nullified by the majority," a self-deprecating rabbinic formula.
[v] An abbreviation for "son of the honorable Rabbi."
[vi] An abbreviation for "may his Rock preserve him," a blessing for the living.
[vii] His grandmother had both an Italian name (Fiorita) and a Hebrew name (Bat-Sheva).
[viii] An abbreviation for "the honorable Rabbi, our teacher."
[ix] An abbreviation for "of blessed memory," used for the deceased.
[x] Referring to families expelled from France in the medieval Jewish expulsions, establishing the author's Sephardic lineage.

ולא גמרנא והדרנא אלא מגשש
אורחתא דאמא אנא.[i] והנני
היום במורא רבא מתאבק בעפר
רגלי רבותי[ii] ומקבל מרותם
עלי וברשותם גרמא יבישא
דנפיל בחלקי[iii] הגם שהוא בצק
שבסדקה עריבה[iv] אוני תערב
לנערים יושבי שירה[v] הסקתי
אותו על פתורי דאינון זעירי
דמגרגשי גרמי[vi] ובגואלקי.
פי׳ סקי אייתי להון בזוזא
עבורא.[vii] ואולי גם לאוכלי
בשרא שמינא אפתורא דדהבא
עיניהם יראו וישמחו ולאו
דאינון צריכין לי ולמילי כי
האי לבני מחוזא דבר מועט
נינהו דשמעתתי דידהו מרפסן
איגרי[viii] אלא לתועלת כללי
כי למה זה נגרע אנחנו עם
אלהי אברהם מלחפש באמתחות
תורתנו ולהמציא לה ממנו אלינו
המצאה נבונה להקריב קרבן
נשמתנו לריח ניחוח לפני מלכנו
ה׳ צבאות שמו בהדרת קדש.
הלא תסולה בכתם אופיר[ix] אם
תהיה לכל א׳ מן המוכן בעט
ברזל ועופרת[x] דרושים מיוחדים

rather grope along the path of my mother.

And now, with great reverence, I humble myself in the dust at my teachers' feet, accepting their authority over me. With their permission, I offer the dry bone that has fallen to my lot, though it is but dough in the cracks of the kneading trough. My words may please the young who sit in song. I have placed it on my small tables, which are tiny and bare-boned. As they say, "Bring them a small amount of grain for a zuz." And perhaps even those who eat fatty meat at golden tables will see and rejoice—not that they need me or words like these, for to city-dwellers these are trifling matters, as their discussions shatter roofs. 670R 675R

Rather, I do this for the general benefit, for why should we, the people of Abraham's God, be diminished[1] from searching through the sacks of our Torah and devising from it a proper invention for ourselves, to offer our souls as a pleasing fragrance[2] before our King, the Lord of Hosts is His name, in holy splendor? Would it not be valuable, worth fine gold of Ophir, if everyone had ready at hand, inscribed with an iron pen and lead, special sermons, psalms, requests, and arranged and organized verses? All the more so for the simple folk like myself or those lesser than me, who comprise the vast majority, so that they may meditate or instruct others to meditate on 680R 685R 690R

[1] This phrase echoes Numbers 9:7, where people who couldn't offer the Passover sacrifice asked why they should be diminished or excluded.

[2] This phrase uses Temple sacrifice terminology to describe spiritual devotion, suggesting the book serves as a substitute for Temple worship.

[i] An Aramaic expression of humility: "although I am neither wise nor a seer, and I have not fully learned or mastered, but rather grope along the path of my mother."

[ii] A traditional expression of humility, referring to sitting at the feet of teachers and being covered in the dust they kick up—indicating complete devotion to learning from them.

[iii] An Aramaic expression meaning "the dry bone that has fallen to my lot," a metaphor for the limited knowledge or resource the author possesses.

[iv] A metaphor comparing his contribution to dough stuck in the cracks of a kneading trough—seemingly insignificant but still of some value.

[v] Literally "those who sit in song," referring to young students who recite Torah passages melodically as they learn.

[vi] An Aramaic expression describing tables that are small and bare-boned, continuing the metaphor of limited resources.

[vii] An Aramaic expression meaning "Bring them a small amount of grain for a zuz," suggesting providing modest but valuable sustenance.

[viii] An Aramaic expression meaning "their discussions shatter roofs," referring to sophisticated scholarly discourse that is beyond the author's level.

[ix] A biblical allusion to Job 28:16, referring to something of great value, comparable to the fine gold of Ophir.

[x] A biblical allusion to Job 19:24, referring to writing something permanently, as if engraved with an iron pen and lead.

ומזמורים ובקשות ופסוקים
ערוכים ומסודרים וכ״ש לפני
הפתאים באנוש בערבי או נגרע
ממני כי הם רובא דרובא[i] למען
יחגו או יצוו לאחרים שיהגו בהם
לפניהם בכל עת מוטה בצוק
העתים[ii] עליו פגום נכנס ופגום
יוצא[iii] או בעת כי יוכח במכאוב
על משכבו:[iv] [v]

these before them at any time of hardship in difficult times, whether one enters imperfect and leaves imperfect, or when one is rebuked with pain upon his sickbed.[1]

על כן אמרתי עת לעשות לה׳
ובעת שמכנסין פזר[vi] ואם חבורי
אדם כמוצי אינו חבור וחרש
שוטה וקטן אין להם מחשבה
ומבר נש זעיר לא ילפין הלא
לנגד עינינו מאמר במדבר רבה
פ׳ י״ד על פסוק דברי חכמים
בדרבונות מנין אתה אומר
שאם שמע אדם דבר מפי קטן
שבישראל יהא בעיניו כשומע
מפי חכם שבישראל ת״ל והיה
אם שמוע תשמעו אל מצותי ולא
כשומע מפי חכם אלא כשומע

Therefore I said, "It is time to act for the Lord," and "When others gather, scatter,"[A] and "If a common person's writings are like finding lost property, they are not considered proper compositions,"[B] and "A deaf-mute, mentally incompetent person, or minor have no intellectual capacity," and "One does not learn from a small person."[C] Yet before our eyes is the statement in Numbers Rabbah, chapter 14, on the verse "The words of the wise are like goads": How do we know that if a person hears something from the mouth of the least significant person in Israel, it should be in his eyes as if hearing from a sage of Israel? The verse teaches, "And it shall come

[A] Or: "and "At a time when others gather in, scatter,"" — This is a reference to a rabbinic saying about when to gather or scatter resources. The alternate translation makes the contrast between 'gathering in' and 'scattering' more explicit.

[B] Or: "and "If the compositions of an ordinary person are like found objects, they are not considered real compositions,"" — This difficult phrase is the author's self-deprecation. The alternate translation more directly conveys the metaphor comparing amateur writings to found objects rather than deliberate compositions.

[C] Or: ""One does not learn from a person of little significance."" — The Aramaic phrase 'bar nash ze'ir' refers not necessarily to physical smallness but to someone of lesser stature or importance in a social or intellectual hierarchy.

[1] This final phrase introduces a central theme of Ma'avar Yabok: providing spiritual guidance for those suffering from illness, particularly near death.

[i] An Aramaic legal term meaning "the vast majority."

[ii] A phrase referring to difficult times or times of hardship.

[iii] A phrase suggesting entering and leaving a situation in an imperfect state, without transformation.

[iv] A biblical allusion to Job 33:19, referring to being rebuked with pain upon one's sickbed, introducing the book's theme of illness as divine correction.

[v] Cf. Book of Job — The author draws on Job's suffering to establish the book's theological framework that illness and suffering can be forms of divine communication and correction, central to Ma'avar Yabok's purpose. | Cf. Psalms — This quotation establishes the author's hope for divine elevation despite his lowly state, setting up the book's theme of divine mercy toward those in distress. | Cf. Numbers — The author echoes the question asked by those who couldn't offer the Passover sacrifice, suggesting that his work provides a means for ordinary people to participate in spiritual service despite their limitations.

[vi] This is a reference to a rabbinic principle found in Berakhot 63a that teaches "At a time when others are gathering in [Torah], scatter [your seeds]; at a time when others scatter, gather in." It suggests strategic timing in religious activity.

מפי חכמים שנאמר וגו׳ ולא
בשומע מפי חכמים אלא בשומע
מפי סנהדרי גדולה וכו׳ ולא
בשומע מפי סנהדרי גדולה אלא
בשומע מפי משה ולא בשומע מפי
משה אלא בשומע מפי ה׳ שנא׳
נתנו מרועה אחד ושלמה למד
לאדם דעת מן הנמלה השפלה
ומן הכל אדם יכול ללמוד הגם
כי הרי זה בא ללמד ונמצא למד.
ואמרו בשה״ש רבה כשם שאין
גדול מתבייש לומר לקטן השקיני
נא מעט מים כך בד״ת אין הגדול
מתבייש לומר לקטן למדני
דבר אחד בתורה ואמר במס׳
ברכות טבא ביעתא מגילגלתא
משיתא קיסי סולתא.[i] ואמרו
ג״כ במדרש קהלת דף ס״ט ע״ב
יהיה בעיניך דור שבא כדור
שהולך שנא תאמר אלו היה
ר״ע קיים הייתי קורא לפניו
אלו היה ר׳ זירא ור׳ יוחנן
קיימים הייתי שונה לפניהם.
ואמרו פ״ד דמציעא כל המקטין
עצמו על ד״ת בעה״ז נעשה גדול
לעה״ב וכל המשים עצמו כעבד
לד״ת בעה״ז נעשה חפשי לעה״ב
דכתיב קטן וגדול שם הוא.[ii][iii]

to pass, if you shall hearken diligently to my commandments." And not just as hearing from a sage, but as hearing from sages, as it says, etc. And not just as hearing from sages, but as hearing from the Great Sanhedrin, etc. And not just as hearing from the Great Sanhedrin, but as hearing from Moses. And not just as hearing from Moses, but as hearing from the mouth of God, as it says, "Given from one shepherd." And Solomon taught people knowledge from the lowly ant, and from everything a person can learn, even though one who comes to teach may end up learning himself.[1] 710R 715R 720R

And they said in Song of Songs Rabbah: Just as a great person is not embarrassed to say to a lesser one,[2] "Please give me a little water to drink," so too with words of Torah—a great person should not be embarrassed to say to a lesser one, "Teach me one thing about Torah." And it says in Tractate Berakhot: "A single egg is better than six measures of fine flour."[A] They also said in Ecclesiastes Midrash, page 69b: "The generation that comes should be in your eyes like the generation that goes. Do not say, 'If Rabbi Akiva were alive, I would read before him; if Rabbi Zeira and Rabbi Yochanan were alive, I would study before them.'" And they said in Chapter 4 of Bava Metzia: "Whoever makes himself small for the sake of words of Torah in this world becomes great in the World to Come, and whoever makes himself like 725R 730R 735R

[A] Or: ""One egg is better than six kav of fine flour."" — This Talmudic proverb uses the specific measurement 'kav' rather than a generic 'measure.' The saying means that sometimes a small amount of substantial food is better than a larger amount of less nourishing food, metaphorically suggesting that a small, valuable teaching is better than many less valuable ones.

[1] This is a reference to a Talmudic saying found in Taanit 7a that "I have learned much from my teachers, more from my colleagues, and the most from my students"—suggesting that teaching others is itself a learning experience.

[2] The author is drawing a parallel between asking for water (a basic physical need where status differences become irrelevant) and asking for Torah knowledge (a spiritual need where one should similarly disregard status hierarchies).

[i] This Aramaic saying from Berakhot 44b means "One egg is better than six kav of fine flour"—a proverb suggesting that sometimes a small amount of substantial food is better than a larger amount of less nourishing food. The author uses this metaphorically to suggest that his small contribution might be more valuable than it appears.

[ii] This quote from Job 3:19 ("Small and great are there") is interpreted in the rabbinic context to mean that in the World to Come, the spiritual hierarchy may be reversed—those who humble themselves for Torah study in this world will be elevated in the next.

[iii] Cf. Song of Songs Rabbah — The author uses this reference to support his argument for humility in Torah learning—that even great scholars should be willing to learn from those of lesser stature. This reinforces the book's theme that wisdom can come from unexpected sources and that pride should not prevent one from gaining knowledge that might be spiritually beneficial, especially regarding preparation for death. | Cf. Numbers Rabbah — The author uses this reference

a servant for words of Torah in this world becomes free in the World to Come, as it is written, 'Small and great are there.'" 740R

ובזה יזכו השומעים לשתי
שולחנות[i] כי ההוגה לפניהם
יוסיף דעת כמ״ש במדרש משלי
דף ס״ט ע״ב מתוך שאתה
מלמד אתה למד שנאמר נפש
ברכה תדושן ומרוה גם הוא
יורה.[ii] וזכותא דרבים דעדיף
אהניא לי שטתייהו ותורת אמת
היא סמכתני עד כי בעזר המאיר
לארץ ולדרים אדר נטעתי
ע״ד שנאמר אדיר במרום ה׳
או אדרא בדאמרו בי״ט פ״ב
אמרי אנשי מאי אדרא דקיימא
לדרי דרין.[iii] וחברתי חדושים
ודרושים שונים אשר יחד כולם
דברי פרישות וטהרה וקדושה
משלשים ותמכתים בימין הענוה
והבושה ויחסתים בשם מעבר יבק
להקריבם ולהקטירם באהבה
ובמורא לפני כל העדה קדושה
בתוך עלמות תופפות יעברו
דרך גשר רעוע מעולם התמורה
והכליון[iv] אשר עוותו המצב

Through this, the listeners will merit two tables,[1] for the one who meditates before them will increase knowledge, as it is written in Midrash Proverbs, page 69b: "From teaching others, you yourself learn," as it says: "A generous soul will prosper, and 745R one who waters will himself be watered." And the merit of the many, which is superior, has benefited me through their approach, and the Torah of truth has supported me, until with the help of the One who illuminates the earth and its inhabitants, I 750R have planted magnificence,[2] as it is said: "The Lord is majestic on high," or "assembly" as they said in Yom Tov, chapter 2: "People say, what is an assembly? That which endures for generations."

I have composed various innovations and 755R discourses which together all express words of abstinence, purity, and holiness, thirty in number, and I have supported them with the right hand of humility and modesty. I have named them "Ma'avar Yabok"[3] (Crossing of the Jabbok), to offer and burn 760R them with love and reverence before the entire holy congregation. Like maidens playing timbrels,[4] they will cross over a rickety bridge from the world

[1]The metaphor of 'two tables' (שתי שולחנות) is a rabbinic concept referring to benefits in both this world and the World to Come, suggesting the spiritual teachings provide immediate and eternal rewards.

[2]The Hebrew 'אדר נטעתי' contains a wordplay connecting to both 'magnificence' and possibly the month of Adar, while also referencing the concept of an 'assembly' (אדרא) that endures for generations.

[3]The book's title refers to the biblical Jabbok River crossing where Jacob wrestled with an angel (Genesis 32), serving as a metaphor for the soul's transition from life to death.

[4]This image alludes to Exodus 15:20 where women celebrated the crossing of the Red Sea with timbrels, creating a parallel between that redemptive crossing and the soul's journey after death.

to establish the principle that all Torah wisdom ultimately comes from God, regardless of who transmits it. This supports his implicit argument that readers should value his work Ma'avar Yabok despite his self-proclaimed unworthiness, as the teachings it contains have divine origin. This reference elevates the spiritual authority of the text while maintaining the author's humble posture.

[i]The concept of 'two tables' here likely refers to benefiting both in this world and the World to Come, or possibly to both physical and spiritual sustenance.

[ii]This is a quote from Proverbs 11:25, which teaches that those who are generous will themselves be enriched—here applied to teaching and sharing spiritual wisdom.

[iii]The term 'adra' (assembly) has kabbalistic significance, referring to special mystical gatherings or compilations. The phrase 'that which endures for generations' emphasizes the lasting spiritual impact the author hopes his work will have.

[iv]This metaphor of crossing a 'rickety bridge' from the 'world of exchange and destruction' represents the soul's precarious journey from the physical world (characterized by impermanence and mortality) to the spiritual realm.

השמיימי להתקשר במעדנים
היחוד והברכה והקדושה ובזה
תעבור המנחה מנחת בכורים
על פנינו ונעבר את מעבר יבק
להתאבק בה׳ איש מלחמה.[i] עד
עלות השחר שהוא התחיה כי אז
לא יעקב יאמר עוד לנשמתנו
ולגופנו רק ישראל[ii] כי נהיה
ממלכת כהנים ונזכה לראות
אלהים פנים אל פנים כי יזרח
לנו שמש צדקה ומרפא וכל
עצמם של דרושים אלו הרבה
מהם נכונים ונאותים להשיחם
ולהגות בהם לפני חולה בתחלת
אוכלא לפצוחי עינא פקיחא
דיליה במילי מעלייתא קודם
שיכבד קצתו על קצתו ורעיונוהי
יבהלוניה ובמה יתרצה אם לא
בבקש מטו לרפואתו וקצת
מהם מיוסדים ומיוחדים למי
שקרבו ימיו למות ונשמתו
הטהורה צווחא ואמרא אפיקו
לי כ״ר כ״ר מהכא הדין גופא
אטומטא[iii] כי אעברה נא ואראה
את הארץ הטובה אשר בעבר
דנהר ימינא וחמי נהורא דמלכא
סבא וההר הטוב הזה דהוא
יצרא דעבירה דאתלבן בתלגא
חיוורא[iv] כי שם צוה ה׳ היחוד
והברכה והקדושה כי בשומעו

of exchange and destruction, which has distorted the heavenly state, to connect with the delights of unification, blessing, and holiness. Through this, the offering—a first-fruits offering—will pass before us, and we will cross the ford of Jabbok to wrestle with the Lord, the Man of War, until the dawn rises, which is the resurrection. For then our souls and bodies will no longer be called Jacob, but Israel, as we will become a kingdom of priests and merit seeing God face to face, for the sun of righteousness will shine upon us with healing. 765R 770R

The essence of these discourses—many of them are appropriate and suitable to discuss and meditate upon before a sick person at the beginning of his illness, to open his watchful eye with excellent words[1] before his condition becomes too burdensome and his thoughts trouble him. How will he be appeased if not by seeking relief for his healing? And some of them are established and designated for one whose days are drawing near to death, when his pure soul cries out saying: "Take me out from here, from this blocked body,[2] that I may cross over and see the good land that is beyond the river on the right, and behold the light of the Ancient King, and this good mountain, which is the evil inclination that has been whitened like snow."[3] For there the Lord has commanded unity, blessing, and holiness. 775R 780R 785R 790R

When he hears how great is the goodness his Creator has stored up for those who fear His name, and that His goodness is in His hand until the crushing

[1] The original uses Aramaic expressions (לפצוחי עינא פקיחא דיליה במילי מעלייתא) that I've rendered in comprehensible English while preserving the meaning of awakening spiritual awareness through valuable teachings.

[2] This passage uses Aramaic expressions to dramatize the soul's desire to leave the physical body, which it experiences as a confinement. The original includes emphatic repetition (כ״ר כ״ר) expressing urgency.

[3] This kabbalistic image (יצרא דעבירה דאתלבן בתלגא חיוורא) describes the transformation of the evil inclination into something pure in the afterlife—a profound mystical concept about ultimate spiritual redemption.

[i] This alludes to Jacob wrestling with the divine being at the Jabbok ford (Genesis 32:22-32), which the author uses as a metaphor for the soul's struggle during the transition from life to death.

[ii] This references Jacob's name change to Israel after his struggle at the Jabbok (Genesis 32:28), suggesting that after death and resurrection, the soul and body will achieve a higher spiritual status, just as Jacob became Israel.

[iii] This Aramaic expression depicts the soul crying out to be released from the physical body, which it experiences as a confinement. The repeated 'כ״ר כ״ר' likely represents an intensified form of 'now' or 'immediately', emphasizing the soul's urgent desire for liberation.

[iv] This striking kabbalistic image describes the evil inclination (yetzer ha-ra) being transformed and purified 'white as snow', suggesting that in the afterlife, even our negative inclinations are redeemed and transformed.

מה רב טוב בוראו אשר צפון
ליראי שמו וכי בידו טובו עד
דכדוכה של נפש מקול המות
לא יחת כ״ב ומהמון מביתתו
לא יענה כי שמה ינוחו וגיעי
כח והיציאה מרחם לצדיק היום
ההוא לו הוא לידת הגוף וביום
מיתתו אז הוא לידת הנפש.[i] צא
נא אחי למען שמך שים עיניך
בדברי החכם בעל העקדה שער
כ״ב דף ס״ו ע״ב על פסוק
ותשחק ליום אחרון במשל יפה
שהמשיל על בית המנוחה של
עולם הנשמות והתירוץ שאלה
שנשאלה לו על טוביות הנשמה
אחר פטירתה כי באמת מתקו
מיליו ומה לנו להעתיק דבר בלי
חדוש פוק חזי תמן.[ii] ומובטחים
אנו ברחמי שמים כי בהתישב
על לב האדם דרושים אלו מידי
שומעו אותם כל טהר ידים יוסיף
אומץ וילהיבו את לבו ויסירו
ערלת לבבו להיות פניו מועדות
ולאזור כגבר חלציו להתחזק
ולהתאמץ בעבודת שמים.[iii]

of the soul, he will not be terrified by the sound of death, nor will he be affected by the noise of its crushing, for there the weary find rest. For the righteous, the day of emergence from the womb is the birth of the body, and the day of his death is the birth of the soul.[1]

Go now, my brother, for your sake, set your eyes upon the words of the sage, the author of the Akedah, Gate 22, page 66b, on the verse "She laughs at the final day," in the beautiful parable he gave about the house of rest in the world of souls, and the answer to the question asked of him about the goodness of the soul after its departure. Truly, his words are sweet, and why should we copy something without innovation? Go and see there for yourself.

We are assured by the mercies of Heaven that when these discourses settle upon a person's heart as he hears them, every person of clean hands will gain strength, his heart will be inflamed, and the foreskin of his heart will be removed, so that his face will be set and he will gird his loins like a man to strengthen and fortify himself in the service of Heaven.

[1] This theological formulation frames death as the soul's birth into spiritual existence, inverting the conventional understanding of birth and death to present a positive view of mortality as spiritual transition.

[i] This is a profound theological statement framing death not as an end but as the soul's birth into a higher spiritual existence—inverting the usual understanding of birth and death.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase meaning 'go out and see there' directs the reader to consult the original source (Sefer HaAkedah) rather than relying on a secondary citation, reflecting the author's scholarly approach.

[iii] Cf. Midrash Proverbs — The author uses this rabbinic quote to establish that through teaching others spiritual matters, the teacher also gains knowledge. This supports his purpose in creating the book as both helping others and developing his own understanding. | Cf. Proverbs 11:25 — This biblical verse reinforces the idea that those who give spiritual guidance to others will themselves be spiritually enriched, establishing the reciprocal nature of teaching and learning. | Cf. Genesis 32:22-32 — The title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok) directly references Jacob's transformative night struggle before meeting Esau. This becomes a central metaphor for the soul's transition from life to death, suggesting that death, like Jacob's crossing, is a transformative spiritual passage. | Cf. Malachi 3:20 (4:2 in some translations) — This prophetic verse is used to describe the ultimate spiritual reward at resurrection, comparing it to the rising sun. The author uses this to provide hope and comfort regarding death, framing it as a transition to a greater spiritual light. | Cf. Psalm 37:37 — The reference to 'the house of rest in the world of souls' reflects the Psalm's teaching about the peaceful end of the righteous, reinforcing that death leads to spiritual rest for the virtuous. | Cf. Sefer HaAkedah (The Binding of Isaac) by Rabbi Isaac Arama — The author directs readers to this philosophical work for deeper understanding of the soul's journey after death, showing how his work builds upon established Jewish philosophical tradition. | Cf. Zohar — The mystical language about the 'Ancient King' (מלכא סבא) and the whitening of the evil inclination reflect Zoharic concepts about the soul's purification and divine encounters after death, establishing the kabbalistic framework of the author's approach.

ובהרבה מדרושים אשר אציע
לפני בינותי בכתובים ובמאמרי
חז״ל בגמ׳ ובמדרשים חלוקים
ואגדות ודברי ספר הזהר פקודין
ור״מ ותקונים[i] וכיוצא ומהם
האיר ה׳ עיני וחדשתי ומצאתי
מאכל בריאה עם נחלי דבש
וחמאה ואלומי תהלות ורוב
הודאות לאשר גמלני וזכני וכל
א׳ מהם נימוקם עמם למען לא
תשכח ולא ימושו מפי לעולם
כדאמרו בירו׳ בפסחים ר׳
זעירא בשם ר״א כל תורה שאין
לה בית אב אינה תורה ופירושו
שאין לה דוגמא ממקום אחר
אפי׳ יהיה למשה מסיני קרוב
להשתכח: ע״כ אם באולי ימצא
איזה שגיאה אל יתלו בוקי
סריקי אלא בי.[ii] כי חטאתי
בשביל שלא ידעתי. אמנם קצתם
הם דברים מקובלים איש מפי
איש נאמנים לשומעיהם וקצתם
כתובים על ספר ותלמיד מזעיר
תלמידיהם אני ומימיהם אני
שותה. ברם משכילי עמנו ביארו
הדברים לחכמים המבינים
מדעתם הרחבה ושנו להם
מדותיהם בראשי פרקים כי
לחכימא ברמיזה[iii] והרבה מהם
בלי ראיה בהלכה למשה מסיני
ואני באתי אחריהם לבארם
בקצת ועוד לעשות להם סמוכות
מדברי חז״ל באופן כי לא
יהיה דומה שומע מפי הרב

In the many discourses I will present, I have contemplated the Scriptures, sayings of our Sages in the Talmud, various midrashim, aggadot, and the words of the Zohar—its commandments, Ra'aya Mehemna, Tikkunim, and similar works. Through these, the Lord has illuminated my eyes.[1] I have developed new insights and found nourishing food along with streams of honey and butter,[2] offering sheaves of praise and abundant thanksgiving to the One who has rewarded and privileged me. For each of these teachings, I have provided their reasoning so they will not be forgotten nor depart from my mouth forever, as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud in Pesachim: "Rabbi Ze'ira said in the name of Rabbi Eleazar, 'Any Torah teaching without a source foundation is not Torah,'" meaning that without a parallel example from elsewhere, even if it was given to Moses at Sinai, it is likely to be forgotten. 820R 825R 830R

Therefore, if perhaps some error is found, let no empty accusations be made against others, but rather against me, for I have erred because I did not know. However, some of these teachings are received traditions passed from person to person, reliable to those who hear them, while others are written in books. I am but a minor student of their disciples, and from their waters I drink. Still, the scholars of our people have explained these matters to the wise who understand through their broad knowledge, teaching them principles in outline form, for to the wise a hint suffices. Many of these teachings require no proof, like laws given to Moses at Sinai,[3] and I have come after them to explain them somewhat and to provide additional support from the words of our Sages, so that hearing from a teacher will not be 835R 840R 845R

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'עיני׳ 'האיר ה is a common biblical and rabbinic expression indicating divine inspiration or enlightenment in understanding sacred texts.

[2] The author uses metaphorical language of food and sweetness to describe the spiritual and intellectual nourishment he found in his studies, drawing on biblical imagery of the promised land flowing with milk and honey.

[3] The phrase 'הלכה למשה מסיני' (law given to Moses at Sinai) refers to traditions considered so authoritative they're attributed to divine revelation at Sinai, even when they lack explicit textual sources in the Torah.

[i] The author lists his textual sources, including Talmud, midrashim, aggadot, and multiple sections of the Zohar. 'ר״מ' is an abbreviation for 'Ra'aya Mehemna' (Faithful Shepherd), a section of the Zohar, while 'תקונים' refers to 'Tikkunei Zohar', another kabbalistic text in the Zoharic corpus.

[ii] The phrase 'בוקי סריקי' (bukei sriki) is an Aramaic expression meaning 'empty pitchers' or figuratively 'empty accusations.' The author is using a rhetorical formula of humility, taking personal responsibility for any errors while implicitly demonstrating his erudition.

[iii] An Aramaic expression meaning 'to the wise, a hint is sufficient'—suggesting that knowledgeable readers will understand deeper meanings with minimal explanation.

865 לשומע מפי תלמיד. ומקום
הניחו לנו אבותינו. מלבד שכן
דרכה של תורה תצפון לישרים
תושיה וה׳ יתן חכמה מפיו דעת
ותבונה. וכל נפשות ישראל
870 צפון להם חלק בתורת ה׳ מיום
שעמדו רגלי אבותינו על הר
סיני ואין אדם נוגע במוכן
לזולתו. והערוני רעיוני וכן
עלה במחשבה לפני להפיק מגן
875 אמירי ספרי זה ולכוננו ולסעדו
על ד׳ אופנים[i] ורוח החיה יהיה
באופנים אלו: [ii]

the same as hearing from a student. Our ancestors 850R
have left room for us to contribute, besides which
this is the way of Torah—it stores wisdom for the
upright, and the Lord gives wisdom; from His mouth
come knowledge and understanding. All souls of
Israel have a portion reserved for them in God's 855R
Torah from the day our ancestors stood at Mount
Sinai, and no person touches what is prepared for
another. My thoughts have stirred me, and thus
it arose in my mind[A] to produce this book, my
precious shield,[1] and to establish and support it 860R
upon four foundations,[B] with the spirit of life within
these foundations:

בבא קמא ממנו שמו קראתי
מאמר שפתי צדק[iii] כי בו
880 יצטדקו ויתהללו בשערים
מעשיהם של כל ישראל ופרקיו
יהיו ארבעים[iv] ובתוכו באו

I have named the first section of this work[C] "The
Discourse of Righteous Lips,"[D] for in it the deeds
of all Israel shall be justified and praised in the 865R
gates.[2] It contains forty chapters, and within it are
verses, remedies, and stories designed according to

[A] Or: "My contemplations have awakened me, and so it occurred to me" — This alternate translation captures the poetic quality of the Hebrew while maintaining the sense of internal inspiration. It's slightly less literal but more natural in English.

[B] Or: "and to structure and fortify it upon four pillars" — This alternative uses 'pillars' instead of 'foundations' to better convey the architectural metaphor in the Hebrew, with 'structure and fortify' capturing the intent of 'establish and support.'

[C] Or: "From its first entrance" — The phrase 'בבא קמא' could be interpreted literally as 'first gate' or 'first entrance,' which would change the meaning to indicate the book begins with this section rather than the author naming it. However, the context strongly suggests the author is naming the first section, making the original translation more appropriate.

[D] Or: "I have called its name 'The Discourse of Righteous Lips,'" — This translation is more literal and preserves the Hebrew sentence structure, though the original translation captures the meaning effectively while being more natural in English.

[1] The phrase 'מגן אמירי ספרי זה' contains a play on words that's difficult to fully capture in translation. 'מגן' can mean shield/protection, while 'אמירי' suggests both 'my sayings/words' and something precious or exalted.

[2] This phrase alludes to Proverbs 31:31, where the virtuous woman's works 'praise her in the gates,' suggesting that proper end-of-life practices bring honor to the Jewish community.

[i] The author is describing the structure of his book Ma'avar Yabok, stating that it will be organized around four foundations or aspects, corresponding to the four letters of 'Yabok' (יבק), as he will elaborate in the following text.

[ii] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Pesachim — The author uses this citation to justify his methodological approach of providing supporting evidence from rabbinic literature for his interpretations and insights | Cf. Zohar — By emphasizing his reliance on kabbalistic literature, particularly the Zohar, the author establishes the mystical orientation of his work Ma'avar Yabok | Cf. Mount Sinai revelation — This reference connects the author's work to the divine revelation at Sinai, suggesting that his teachings tap into the eternal wisdom granted to all Jewish souls at that foundational moment

[iii] This is the title of the first major section of Ma'avar Yabok. The name 'Siftei Tzedek' (Righteous Lips) has theological significance, suggesting speech that is both morally righteous and spiritually effective.

[iv] The number forty has symbolic significance in Jewish tradition, often representing a complete spiritual process or transformation (e.g., forty days of the flood, forty years in the wilderness, forty days of Moses on Mount Sinai).

הפסוקים והתיקונים והספורים
המכוונים כפי שכל המך להצדיק
885 נפש החולה להעלות לו ארוכה
ומרפא או אם יפקיד נשמתו
ביד אל עם עצומים יחלק
שלל[i] בשומרו את דברי הברית
הזאת (והרבה דרושים מועילים
890 ועקריים באו אגב והתוספת רבה
על העקר[ii]): [iii]

common understanding to justify the soul of the sick person—to bring healing and recovery, or, should he entrust his soul to God, to share the spoils with the mighty[A] by keeping the words of this covenant. (Many beneficial and essential expositions have been included along the way, and the additions exceed the original foundation.[1]) 870R

בבא מציעא ממנו בניתיו בשם
מאמר שפת אמת פרקיו הם
שלשים ושבע בו יתבאר דרושים
895 ותקונים הראויים להעשות
למתים וזהו חסד של אמת עם
הרבה דרושים אחרים מזהב
ומפז יקרים: [iv]

The second discourse derived from it[B] I've titled "Ma'amar Sfat Emet" (Discourse of Truthful Speech). It consists of thirty-seven chapters[2] that explain the proper rituals and rectifications to be performed for the deceased, which is the true kindness [performed for those who cannot repay], along with many other precious expositions more valuable than gold and fine gold. 875R 880R

[A] Or: "or if he entrusts his soul to God's hand, he will divide spoils with the mighty" — This alternative is more literal and directly references Isaiah 53:12, which uses similar phrasing about dividing spoils with the mighty. It preserves the biblical allusion more explicitly, though the original translation effectively conveys the meaning.

[B] Or: "The middle section of it" — A more literal translation of 'bava metzia' would be 'middle gate' or 'middle section,' which refers to the second of three sections in Talmudic organization. The author is using this terminology metaphorically to indicate the second major division of his work.

[1] The author acknowledges that the work expanded significantly beyond its initial conception, with additional teachings incorporated throughout the composition process.

[2] The number thirty-seven may have mystical significance, as numbers often do in kabbalistic works. In gematria (Jewish numerology), 37 is the value of 'yechidah' (the highest level of the soul).

[i] This is an allusion to Isaiah 53:12, which in its original context refers to the reward of the righteous servant who bears the sins of many. Here it is applied to the dying person who has properly prepared spiritually.

[ii] This parenthetical comment, indicating that the additions exceed the original foundation, reveals the organic development of Ma'avar Yabok, which apparently grew significantly beyond its initial conception as the author incorporated more material.

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 53:12 — The author is drawing a parallel between the dying person who entrusts their soul to God and the biblical righteous servant who receives divine rewards after suffering. This suggests that proper spiritual preparation for death leads to spiritual rewards. | Cf. Proverbs 31:31 — The author adapts this praise of the virtuous woman to refer to how proper spiritual practices during illness and death will bring honor to all Israel. This suggests that proper end-of-life rituals reflect positively on the entire community. | Cf. Bible—References to covenants — The author frames proper end-of-life practices as a form of covenant observance, suggesting that the guidelines in this section have binding religious significance similar to biblical covenants.

[iv] Cf. Rashi on Genesis 47:29 — The phrase 'chesed shel emet' (true kindness) is commonly understood, following Rashi's comment on Genesis 47:29, as referring specifically to kindness shown to the dead, who cannot repay the favor. This is why burial and funeral practices are considered the ultimate form of selfless kindness.

בבא בתרא ממנו כשמו כן הוא
900 ונאה לו ליקרא מאמר שפתי
רננות המלמד לאדם דעת לרנן
לאל בעת עשיתו חסד של אמת
ומלין לצד עילאה ימלל על
כל מעשה ובסוף המאמר באו
905 פרקי גיהנם ופרקי ג״ע וכוונת
היחוד.[i] פרקיו תאיו ואולמיו הם
[iii] [ii]מו:

The final section from it[A] is true to its name,[1] and
it is fitting for it to be called "Discourse of Lips of
Praise," which teaches a person knowledge to sing 885R
praise to God when performing true kindness,[2] and
to speak words toward the Most High concerning
all deeds. At the end of the discourse are chapters
about Gehinnom and chapters about the Garden
of Eden,[B] and the intention of unification.[3] Its 890R
chapters, chambers, and halls number forty-six.[C]

האחרון הכי נכבד שמו נאה
לו והוא נאה לשמו עתר ענן
910 הקטרת[iv] יכונה. ובו ג׳ מיני
דרושים שונים. חלק ראשון ממנו
בו יתעלה סדר פטום הקטרת
עם שאר דרושים אגביה ופרקיו
ח׳. החלק השני יקרא קרבן

The final and most honored discourse bears a name
that suits it well, and it is itself well-suited to its
name: "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (Cloud of Incense
Prayer[D]). It contains three different types of ex- 895R
positions. The first part elevates the order of the
incense preparation, along with other related expo-
sitions, and consists of eight chapters. The second

[A] Or: "The concluding part of the book" — The phrase 'Bava Batra' could be interpreted as 'last gate' or 'final section,' but in context it clearly refers to the concluding part of the book Ma'avar Yabok rather than the Talmudic tractate of the same name.

[B] Or: "sections concerning Hell and Paradise" — While the literal translation is accurate, 'Hell and Paradise' might be more immediately recognizable to modern readers, though 'Gehinnom and Garden of Eden' preserves the specific Jewish theological concepts.

[C] Or: "Its chapters, sections, and halls are forty-six in number" — The architectural metaphor used here (chambers and halls) refers to the structure of the text. This alternate translation maintains the architectural imagery while clarifying the meaning.

[D] Or: "The Fragrant Cloud of Incense" — This alternate translation more directly captures the sensory quality implied in the Hebrew term 'eter' which suggests a rising fragrance or pleasant smell. However, the original translation better preserves the liturgical context.

[1] The text makes a wordplay suggesting that the name of this discourse (Siftei Renanot/Lips of Praise) perfectly captures its essence and purpose.

[2] The phrase 'chesed shel emet' (true kindness) specifically refers to care for the dead in Jewish tradition, as it is considered the purest form of kindness since the deceased cannot reciprocate.

[3] In Kabbalistic terminology, 'kavvanat ha-yichud' refers to specific mystical meditations and intentions focused on unifying the divine name and various spiritual worlds, particularly important during prayer and at the time of death.

[i] These three elements—chapters on Gehinnom (Hell), chapters on Gan Eden (Paradise), and teachings on divine unification—represent the mystical culmination of the text, addressing both the afterlife journey of the soul and the ultimate spiritual goal of unifying with the divine.

[ii] The author uses architectural terminology from the Temple (chambers and halls) as a metaphor for the text's structure, implying that studying this discourse is analogous to moving through sacred space.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok structure — This text summarizes the final section of Ma'avar Yabok, explaining its name, purpose, and structure, which complements the earlier outline of the book's organization presented in the introduction. | Cf. Maaseh Merkavah — The architectural language used here (chambers, halls) echoes the tradition of Merkavah mysticism where heavenly palaces and chambers represent spiritual levels and realms of understanding.

[iv] This poetic title for the fourth discourse combines three elements: 'eter' (prayer/supplication), 'anan' (cloud), and 'ketoret' (incense), evoking the ritual incense offering in the ancient Temple as described in Exodus 30:34-38. This reflects the post-Temple Jewish approach of replacing physical sacrifices with prayer and text study.

תענית[i] והוא תקון טוב ויפה ונקל להרגיל בו האדם יום א׳ בחדש לבד לפחות ופרקיו ז׳. החלק השלישי ממאמר הד׳ כניתיו בשם מנחת אהרן[ii] ה״ה סדרים מפסוקי אנ״ך עם מעט בקשות הקשורים בעבותות אהבה ובהם ישירו ויזמרו כל החפץ לקדש עצמו אחר תפלת שחרית ומנחה או קודם להם שכן ה׳ חפץ ובחר בעמו ישראל ביחודי אהב״ה[iii] ופרקיו י״ח:[iv]

part is called “Korban Ta’anit” (Sacrifice of Fasting[1]), and it is a good and beautiful spiritual rectification that one can easily practice at least one day each month; it has seven chapters. The third part of the fourth discourse I have named “Minchat Aharon” (Aaron’s Offering[2]), which consists of arrangements of verses from the Bible with a few supplications bound together with bonds of love. With these, anyone desiring to sanctify themselves may sing and chant[A] after the morning and afternoon prayers, or before them, for this is what the Lord desires and has chosen for His people Israel in the unifications of love.[B] It contains eighteen chapters. 900R 905R 910R

הנה כי תמצית המורה מארבע

The essence taught[C] by these four discourses is

[A] Or: “And through these, all who wish to sanctify themselves shall sing praises and melodies” — This alternate translation emphasizes the musical quality of the devotional practice and captures the spiritual intention more poetically, though the original translation is more concise and accurate.

[B] Or: “through the mystical unifications of AHVH (love)” — This alternate translation makes explicit the kabbalistic connotation that is implicit in the original text, where AHVH likely represents a divine name or mystical acronym related to love and unification in Kabbalistic practice.

[C] Or: “The guiding essence” — The word ‘המורה’ can mean ‘that which teaches/guides,’ making this a slightly more literal rendering, though the current translation effectively captures the meaning in context.

[1] This section presents fasting as a spiritual substitute for Temple sacrifices, reflecting the broader Jewish mystical tradition of transforming bodily practices into spiritual offerings. The author recommends this practice be performed at least monthly, making it accessible even to those who cannot maintain more frequent ascetic practices.

[2] This title creates a deliberate connection between the author (Aaron Berechia) and the biblical High Priest Aaron. Just as Aaron offered incense in the Temple, the author presents these prayer arrangements as a form of spiritual offering that can be made by ordinary individuals in post-Temple Judaism.

[i] Literally ‘Sacrifice of Fasting,’ this term reflects the rabbinic concept that after the Temple’s destruction, fasting could serve as a substitute for sacrificial offerings. The Hebrew word ‘korban’ specifically refers to sacrifices brought to the Temple.

[ii] Literally ‘Aaron’s Offering,’ this title creates a wordplay between the author’s name (Aaron Berechia) and the biblical Aaron (first High Priest). A ‘minchah’ was specifically a grain offering in the Temple, but here refers to a collection of scriptural verses and prayers.

[iii] This phrase reflects kabbalistic terminology where ‘yichudim’ (unifications) refers to mystical practices intended to unify divine attributes. The acronym אהב״ה (AHVH) may represent a divine name or concept related to love, suggesting these prayers create loving unifications in divine realms.

[iv] Cf. Ketoret (Temple incense offering) — The author elevates the recitation of the incense formula to a central spiritual practice that serves as a substitute for the actual Temple offering. This reflects the post-Temple Jewish approach of replacing physical sacrifices with prayer. | Cf. Fasting as sacrifice — The author frames regular fasting as ‘Korban Ta’anit’ (Sacrifice of Fasting), suggesting that monthly fasting serves as a spiritual equivalent to Temple sacrifices, reflecting the broader Jewish mystical tradition of transforming bodily practices into spiritual offerings. | Cf. Aaron as High Priest — By naming the third section ‘Minchat Aharon’ (Aaron’s Offering), the author creates a wordplay connecting himself (Aaron Berechia) with the biblical Aaron, suggesting that these prayers serve as a substitute for the High Priest’s offerings in the Temple. | Cf. Divine unifications (yichudim) — The reference to ‘unifications of love’ (yichudei ahavah) indicates that these prayers are designed not merely as petitions but as mystical practices intended to create cosmic unifications in the divine realms, following Kabbalistic models of prayer as spiritual repair.

מאמרים אלו[i] במאמר ראשון ילמד לאדם דעת לשחר קונו
930 בוידוי ובתפלה ותשובה לעומתו י׳ של יבק שאומרת
י״חו״ד.[ii] המאמר השני הוא להביא ברכה אל נשמת וגוף
האדם בתקונים המתבארים
935 שם. לעומתו הב׳ של יבק האומרת ברכה. במאמר הג׳
בו יקדש אדם עצמו בקרוא או בהשמיע ע״י זולתו לאזניו
דרושיו רמז לזה ק׳ של יבק
940 האומרת קדושה. ובכח היחוד והברכה והקדושה. צדיקים
יירשו ארץ חפץ ונפשותם בטוב
ילינו[iii] ובזה יעלה עתר ענן
הקטרה בקרבן תענית ובמנחתו
945 של אהרן איש החסד ושושבינא
דמטרוניתא[iv] מתחתית לעילית
והארץ תענה את השמים והשמים
יענו את הארץ[v] ורב טוב
לבית ישראל ומספר מפקד

as follows: In the first discourse, one learns how to seek one's Creator[1] through confession, prayer, and repentance, corresponding to the letter Yod of Yabok, which represents unification[2] (Yichud). The second discourse brings blessing to the soul and body of a person through the rectifications explained therein, corresponding to the Bet of Yabok, which signifies blessing (Berachah). In the third discourse, one sanctifies oneself by reading or having others read its expositions to one's ears, alluded to by the Kuf of Yabok, which indicates holiness (Kedushah). And through the power of unification, blessing, and holiness, the righteous will inherit the land of desire and their souls will lodge in goodness. Thus will the cloud of incense prayer ascend[3] through the sacrifice of fasting and through the offering of Aaron, the man of kindness and attendant of the Divine Presence,[A4] from the lowest to the highest realms.[B] Then the earth will answer the heavens,[5] and the heavens will answer the earth, bringing abundant goodness to the House of Israel. The total number of its chambers, halls, 915R 920R 925R 930R

[A]Or: "groomsman of the Divine Queen" — The term 'shoshvin' specifically refers to a groomsman or best man in wedding contexts, and 'matronita' is often specifically translated as the Divine Queen, emphasizing the feminine aspect of divinity in Kabbalah. This alternative more directly preserves the marriage metaphor used in kabbalistic literature.

[B]Or: "from below to above" — A more literal translation that maintains the directional simplicity of the Hebrew while still conveying the ascent from earthly to heavenly realms.

[1]The Hebrew verb 'לשחר' (to seek) has connotations of seeking early in the morning, suggesting an eager, diligent seeking of God.

[2]The original text uses abbreviations marked with quotation marks (י״חו״ד) to indicate that the letter Yod stands for 'Yichud' (unification), a key kabbalistic concept relating to the unification of divine aspects.

[3]The Hebrew term 'עתר ענן הקטרה' combines 'prayer' (עתר), 'cloud' (ענן), and 'incense' (קטרה), evoking the incense offering in the ancient Temple, which is used throughout Ma'avar Yabok as a metaphor for prayer.

[4]The phrase 'שושבינא דמטרוניתא' (attendant of the Divine Presence) is in Aramaic and refers to someone who serves the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). The author creates a wordplay between his own name (Aaron Berechia) and the biblical High Priest Aaron.

[5]This phrase alludes to Hosea 2:23-24, reversing the natural order (usually heaven answers earth) to emphasize how proper spiritual practice creates a reciprocal relationship between upper and lower worlds in kabbalistic thought.

[i]This is a summary statement outlining the essence of all four discourses that make up the book Ma'avar Yabok.

[ii]The author uses a creative device where each letter of the word 'Yabok' (יבק) corresponds to a spiritual quality: Yod (י) represents Yichud (unification), Bet (ב) represents Berachah (blessing), and Kuf (ק) represents Kedushah (holiness).

[iii]This phrase alludes to Psalms 25:13, which speaks of the rewards for those who fear God.

[iv]This Aramaic phrase means 'attendant of the Queen/Divine Presence' and is a kabbalistic term referring to those who serve the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). Here it is applied to Aaron, creating a connection between the biblical Aaron and the author Aaron Berechia.

[v]This is an allusion to Hosea 2:23-24, which describes cosmic harmony and agricultural abundance

תאיו ואולמיו ופרקיו ארבעה
המאמרות אלו יעלו למאה
וחמשים ושבעה:[i][ii]

and chapters[1] across these four discourses amounts to one hundred and fifty-seven. 935R

שלשה המה מטיבי צעד מיני
פסוקים ויחודים ומזמורים
ובקשות אשר באו מפורשים
במאמרים אלו. הקבוץ הראשון
הנבחר כדי להגן בהם מי שעלה
למטה באיזה מיחוש ירבה אל
אלוה בהם תפלה כי יעלה לו
ארוכה וביום השלישי יצמיח לו
ישועה ויעלה בית ה׳ להודות
לה׳ חסדו וימחלו לו כל
עונותיו כדאמרו בפ׳ ד׳ דנדרים
והטעמים מספיקים לרוות נפש
המעיינים למה בחרתי בפסוקים
יביעו וידברו בשפה ברורה
הפרקים האחרונים מאמר הד׳
שחלק ההוא קראתיו בשם מנחת
אהרן וכל החפץ משם ימלא ידו
ויאחז צדיק דרכו ומדברות פיו
יחיה נפשו ויאדיר חסד אל כל
היום ובאלהים יעשה חיל וכלל
העולה משם כי העוסק במקראות
בתפלית ותחינות אין לך מדה
גדולה הימנה ודרך זו דרכתי

There are three that improve one's steps: the types of verses, unifications, psalms, and supplications that are explained in these discourses. The first collection was chosen to protect those who take to their beds with any ailment, that they may offer prayer to God through them, so that healing will come to them, and on the third day salvation will spring forth for them. Then they will ascend to the house of the Lord to give thanks for His kindness, and all their sins will be forgiven, as stated in the fourth chapter of Tractate Nedarim. The reasons are sufficient to satisfy the souls of those who study why I chose verses.[A] The final chapters of the fourth discourse—the section I named "Minchat Aharon" (Aaron's Offering)—will speak clearly.[2] Anyone who desires may fill their hand from there[3] and the righteous will maintain their way, and through the utterances of their mouth they will sustain their soul and magnify God's kindness all day, and through God they will gain strength. The general principle arising from there is that one who engages with scriptural verses in prayers and supplications—there is no greater virtue than this. This is the path 940R 945R 950R 955R

[A] Or: "The reasons provided are sufficient to satisfy the minds of those who study why I chose scriptural verses" — The Hebrew 'nefesh' (soul) is sometimes used idiomatically to refer to the mind or intellect. This alternate translation might better convey the intellectual satisfaction the author promises rather than spiritual satisfaction.

[1] The Hebrew terms 'תאיו ואולמיו ופרקיו' (chambers, halls, and chapters) use architectural metaphors to describe the textual structure of the book, a common device in rabbinic literature.

[2] The author is indicating that his reasoning for preferring scriptural verses in prayer will be fully explained in the later part of his work titled 'Minchat Aharon.'

[3] This is a biblical expression meaning to take or receive something, often used in the context of priestly consecration. Here it means readers can take whatever spiritual wisdom they need from that section.

as signs of covenant restoration. In this context, it suggests that proper spiritual practice creates channels of blessing between heavenly and earthly realms.

[i] The author notes that the four discourses contain a total of 157 sections, chambers, or chapters, providing a comprehensive numerical accounting of the work's structure.

[ii] Cf. Song of Songs 3:11 — The author draws on the Song of Songs tradition of describing spiritual relationships in terms of wedding imagery, casting Aaron (likely referring to himself as the author) as an attendant at the mystical wedding between God and Israel (the Divine Presence or Shekhinah). | Cf. Hosea 2:23-24 — The author employs this prophetic image of cosmic harmony to suggest that proper spiritual practice creates a channel of divine influence flowing between heavenly and earthly realms, resulting in divine blessing. | Cf. Psalms 25:13 — The author draws on biblical promises of reward for the righteous to indicate that following the spiritual system laid out in Ma'avar Yabok leads to both worldly blessing and spiritual fulfillment.

במעירי שחר שלי כי לא העתרתי
דברים קול ענות חלושה לפני
ה׳ אלהים היודע את האיש ואת
שיחו וכמה גרוע כלי זה שעשה
כמוני היום מלספר שבחו הרב
רובא דרובא ממנו בא בדברי
הנבואה ושירי זמרה הקוטפי
מלו״ח עלי שי״ח. דהגם שאמרו
בגמרין פ׳ אלו מציאות ובירו׳
דשבת פ׳ כל כתבי תני רשב״י
העוסק במקרא מדה ואינה מדה.
כבר פי׳ רש״י טעם למה המשנה
והגמ׳ יפים מהמקרא הוא מפני
שתלוים בגירסא ומשתכחים
שבימיהם לא היה הגמ׳ נכתבת
גם לא היה ניתן ליכתב אלא
שנתמעטו הלבבות והתחילו
הדורות לכותבן משום עת
לעשות לה׳ וגו׳ ע״כ. וכן אישר
דבריו בעל יפה מראה. הנה
דאי לאו משום אוקומי גירסא
ודאי כי המקרא שנאמרו בנבואה
ור״הק קודם במעלה לדברי
המשנה והגמ׳ וכ״ש לדברי הגדה
שבאו במשלי הפייטנים ובפרט
באותן שלא קבלום הצבור
עליהם ואי איתנפיין איתנופי
בקולות ערבים הפוכי בקראי
טב מינייהו. ובסדר תפלה כ״ע
מודו דמקרא עיקר דזמן תורה
לחוד וזמן תפלה לחוד. ואמרו
במס׳ עירובין פ״ג כי עמד ר׳
יוחנן בן נורי על רגליו נגד ר׳
יהושע ואמר חזי אנא דבתר
רישא גופא אזיל ופירשו דבריו
כלומר רואה אני כדין וכהלכה
שצריכים אנו להלוך אחר דברי
הראשונים כי טובה צפרנן
מכריסן של אחרונים כדאמרי׳
ביומא פ״ק. ואמרו בבתרא

I followed in my "Illuminators of Dawn" prayer society,[1] for I did not multiply words with a weak voice before the Lord God who knows each person and their conversation, and how inferior is this vessel who has done as I have today rather than recounting His abundant praise, the majority of which comes from the words of prophecy and songs of praise plucked from the fragrant plants upon the bushes. Even though they said in the Gemara chapter "These Findings" and in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shabbat, chapter "All Sacred Writings," Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai taught: "One who engages with Scripture—it is a virtue but not a virtue." Rashi has already explained why the Mishnah and Gemara are superior to Scripture: because they depend on oral recitation and are forgotten, since in their days the Gemara was not written down and was not permitted to be written, except that as hearts diminished and generations began to write them down because "it is time to act for the Lord," etc. Thus far. And the author of Yefeh Mareh[2] confirmed his words. Indeed, were it not for preserving the oral tradition, certainly Scripture, which was spoken through prophecy and divine inspiration, takes precedence over the words of the Mishnah and Gemara, and certainly over words of Aggadah that came in the parables of liturgical poets, especially those that the public did not accept upon themselves. And if they were sifted and eliminated by pleasant voices, turning to Scripture would be better than them. And regarding the order of prayer, everyone agrees that Scripture is essential, for the time for Torah study is separate and the time for prayer is separate.[A] And they said in Tractate Eruvin, chapter 3, that Rabbi Yochanan ben Nuri stood on his feet against Rabbi Joshua and said, "I see that the body follows the head," and they explained his words to mean, "I see according to the law and custom that we must follow the words of the early authorities, for the fingernail of

960R 965R 970R 975R 980R 985R 990R 995R

[A] Or: "And regarding prayer liturgy, all authorities agree that Scripture is foundational, since the time for Torah study is distinct from the time for prayer" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the halakhic (Jewish legal) distinction being made between prayer time and study time, and emphasizes that 'everyone' refers to rabbinic authorities rather than people in general.

[1] The author refers to a prayer group or society called 'Illuminators of Dawn' (מעירי שחר) that he led or participated in, which focused on morning prayers.

[2] This is a commentary on the Jerusalem Talmud by Rabbi Shmuel Yafeh Ashkenazi (1525-1595). The author cites this as an authoritative source confirming Rashi's explanation.

ספ״ה לכל מילי מעלייא עתיקא.
ואמר בברכות פ״ב לעולם יהיו
דבריו של אדם מועטים לפני
הקב״ה. וכל המתנגד לזה אינו
אלא חולק על האמת הברור כי
מארץ תצמח ואבין תיכלא לימא
כי האי מילתא: [i]

the early ones is better than the belly of the later ones," as they said in Yoma, first chapter. And they said in Bava Batra, at the end of chapter 5, "For all excellent matters, the ancient is better." And it was said in Berachot, chapter 2, "A person's words before the Holy One, blessed be He, should always be few." And anyone who opposes this is merely disputing the clear truth, for it springs forth from the earth, and I will understand that consumption will declare such a thing.[1]

1000R

1005R

במאמר השלישי בו יבא קי״ב
פסוקים כמספר יב״ק [ii] עם
הנמשכים אחריהם ועמם שאר
תקונים ותפלות המיוחדים
להאמר אצל מאן דתקיף ליה
עלמא טובא. [iii] ונפשו תאבה
ליעטות כשלמה אורה תחת כנפי
השכינה בלבושי יקר דאתקין
לנפשא ורוחא ונשמתא מזווגא
דמלכא ומטרוניתא [iv] מנהירו

In the third discourse, there will appear 112 verses corresponding to the numerical value of YaBOK (יב״ק),[2] along with those that follow them, and with them other rectifications and prayers specifically designated to be recited for one whom the world greatly oppresses.[A3] And his soul desires to wrap itself like a garment of light under the wings of the Divine Presence, in precious garments that were prepared for the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah from the union of the King and Queen,[4] from the

1010R

1015R

[A] Or: "one who is gravely ill and approaching death" — This more explicit translation clarifies the euphemistic Aramaic phrase which literally means 'one whom the world greatly overpowers,' but in context specifically refers to someone critically ill or dying.

[1] This final phrase is somewhat obscure. 'Consumption' (תיכלא) may refer to destruction or disease, suggesting that denying the superiority of ancient wisdom leads to spiritual or intellectual ruin.
[2] This numerological correspondence is significant because the entire book is structured around the metaphor of crossing the Yabok River (מעבר יבק), representing the soul's transition from life to death. The author carefully selected 112 verses to match this number.
[3] This poetic rendering of the Aramaic phrase 'מאן דתקיף ליה עלמא טובא' refers to someone who is critically ill or dying—literally one who is overpowered by the world.
[4] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the unification of masculine and feminine divine attributes

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fifth Discourse (Eter Anan HaKetoret) — The author refers to the section he named 'Minchat Aharon' (Aaron's Offering), which is part of the fourth discourse. This section apparently contains a detailed explanation of why scriptural verses are superior for prayer. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Tractate Nedarim — The author cites this Talmudic source to support his claim that proper prayer leads to healing and forgiveness of sins, establishing a traditional basis for his approach to using scriptural verses for healing. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Tractate Yoma — The author cites this source to support his argument about the superiority of earlier authorities, using the colorful expression about fingernails and bellies to emphasize the greater wisdom of earlier generations. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shabbat — The author refers to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's teaching about the relative value of studying Scripture, using this as part of his argument for the importance of scriptural verses in prayer.
[ii] The author is noting that 112 verses will be included, as this is the numerical value of the Hebrew letters YaBOK (יב״ק = 10+2+100=112). This numerological correspondence reinforces the book's central metaphor of crossing the Yabok River as a symbol for the soul's transition at death.
[iii] This Aramaic phrase literally means "one whom the world greatly overpowers" and refers to someone who is critically ill or dying.
[iv] This is kabbalistic terminology referring to the mystical union of the masculine aspect of God (the King, associated with Tiferet) and the feminine aspect (the Queen or Matronita, associated with Malkhut/Shekhinah). In Kabbalah, this divine union generates spiritual energy that creates 'garments' for the soul.

דפקודי דאורייתא קדישא דנטע ושתיל בגנתא דארעא ודרקיעא ביומי דהוה בהאי עלמא והשתא כולהו יומי ושני מתקרבין למיעל בלא כסופא קמי מלכא קדישא.[i] ועוד בה שלישיה בסוף המאמר הרביעי אשר הם עולת תמיד ומנחה טהורה ומגישי מנחה לה׳ בצדקה ערב ובקר. וכהן גבר הוא בכולא. והני כיסני מעלי ללבא ומבטלי מחשבתא בישה:[ii][iii]

illumination of the commandments of the holy Torah that he planted and sowed in the garden of earth and heaven during the days when he was in this world. And now all those days and years draw near to enter without shame before the Holy King.[1] And there is yet a third part at the end of the fourth discourse, which are perpetual burnt offerings and pure meal offerings, those who bring an offering to the Lord in righteousness evening and morning. And a man who is a priest is involved in all of this. And these herbs are beneficial for the heart and nullify evil thoughts.[A] 1020R 1025R 1030R

עתה אחינו בית ישראל שמעו יוקח נא מעט מים ממעייני הישועה[iv] הא אינון פסוקי אנ״ך[v] עם הדרושים הבאים

Now, our brethren of the House of Israel, listen! Let a little water be taken from the springs of salvation[2]—these are the verses of the Bible along with the expositions that accompany them. Let us place 1035R

[A] Or: "And these spiritual remedies elevate the heart and dispel negative thoughts" — This translation more clearly conveys the metaphorical nature of the statement, as the author is referring to spiritual practices rather than literal herbs, though the metaphor is drawn from medicinal herb traditions.

(Tiferet and Malkhut). In Kabbalah, this union is understood to generate spiritual energy that creates 'garments' for the soul based on one's Torah observance and good deeds.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that one's Torah study and good deeds create spiritual 'garments' that allow the soul to appear appropriately clothed before God after death, rather than being 'naked' and ashamed.

[2] This opening uses humble language echoing Abraham's hospitality in Genesis 18:4, while employing water as a metaphor for Torah and spiritual sustenance.

[i] This Aramaic phrase describes how one's days and years of Torah observance enable the soul to enter the divine presence 'without shame,' a kabbalistic concept indicating that proper spiritual preparation creates appropriate 'garments' for the soul in the afterlife.

[ii] This is a play on a Talmudic phrase about medicinal herbs that benefit the heart and dispel negative thoughts (Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 40a). Here, the author is metaphorically suggesting that the spiritual remedies contained in his book have healing properties for the soul.

[iii] Cf. Biblical Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River — The author deliberately invokes Jacob's transformative crossing as a spiritual paradigm for death as a transition rather than an ending. The numerical value of יב״ק (112) becomes a structuring principle for the verses intended to guide the soul across this metaphorical river. | Cf. Union of King and Queen — This is a core Zoharic concept referring to the mystical union between the masculine and feminine aspects of God, which generates spiritual energy and blessing. In this context, it suggests that proper observance of Torah commandments creates spiritual garments for the soul through this divine union. | Cf. Wings of the Divine Presence — This biblical metaphor is reinterpreted in kabbalistic terms as the soul finding refuge within the divine feminine aspect (Shekhinah) after death. It suggests that proper spiritual preparation creates a protected space for the soul. | Cf. Three parts of the soul—nefesh, ruach, and neshamah — This division of the soul into three aspects (vital soul, spirit, and higher soul) is fundamental to kabbalistic psychology. The text suggests that each component receives its own spiritual garment or vessel prepared through Torah observance in this life. | Cf. The garden of earth and heaven — This dual garden metaphor suggests that Torah observance creates spiritual fruits in both this world and heavenly realms, which will sustain the soul after death.

[iv] This is a biblical phrase from Isaiah 12:3, 'wells of salvation,' here referring to scriptural verses as sources of spiritual salvation.

[v] אנ״ך (ANaKh) is an acronym for the three divisions of the Hebrew Bible: Torah (Pentateuch), Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings).

לרגלם ונשימם דוברות בפי בני
חבורות גומלי חסדים[i] שבכל
פלך ופלך ועיר ועיר למען
יביאון אותה בפיהם ויגידום
סדרים אלו באזני העולה
מתהומות הארץ ליראות את פני
המלך ה׳ צבאות כי בזה יתנו
אחרית ותקוה טובה לנשמות
הנפטרים בערוגת הבושם
ובקולם קול עוז יוציאו מפיהם
לנגדו מילי קדושה למען יהיה
פי החולה כפיהם ויביע וידבר
ויתחנן לה׳ אלהיו יאסוף רוחו
ונשמתו וישמר צאתו ובואו. עד
כי שולמית[ii] זו תשוב אל ערי
הרכב אלהים רבותים[iii] ויאתיו
חשמנים לקראת בואה ורנן ירננו
שלום בואך ויאמרו באזניה בני
האלהים אחותינו את היי לאלפי
רבבה עוד תעדי תופייך ויצאת
במחול צדיקים בג״ע[iv] ותמונת
ה׳ תביטי ושבעי בהקיץ תמונתו.
ולנגדם היא תעלה ותשיב אמריה
להם לאמר טפסרי מרום משרתי
אלהינו חושו עופו טוסו אפיקו
נא מגן וצנה שמרוני שמרוני
עזרוני עזרוני סמכוני סמכוני
וסוכת שלום פרשו עלי ומכל
צבא היו לי למגן וצנה עד כי
נקרב ונבואה אל המקום אשר

them as rafts[A] in the mouths[1] of members of charitable societies in every region and city, so that they may bring them forth with their lips and recite these arrangements in the ears of one who ascends from the depths of the earth[B] to appear before the King, 1040R
the Lord of Hosts. For in this way, they will provide a good end and hope for the souls of the departed in the bed of spices. With their voice, a voice of strength, they will utter words of holiness before the sick person, so that the mouth of the ill one may be 1045R
like their mouths, expressing, speaking, and beseeching the Lord his God to gather his spirit and soul, and to guard his going out and coming in.

Until this Shulamite returns to the cities of God's chariots,[2] which are myriads, and dignitaries will 1050R
come to greet her arrival, joyfully singing, "Peace upon your coming!" And the sons of God will say in her ears, "Our sister, may you be multiplied thousands of times. You will again adorn yourself with your tambourine and join in the dance of the righ- 1055R
teous in the Garden of Eden. You will gaze upon the image of the Lord and be satisfied upon awakening to His likeness."

And in response to them, she will rise and reply, saying, "Heavenly officers, servants of our God, 1060R
hurry, fly, soar! Please draw forth shield and buckler! Guard me, guard me! Help me, help me! Support me, support me! Spread over me a canopy of peace, and let all the hosts be as a shield and buckler for me until we approach and come to the place which 1065R

[A] Or: "vessels of speech" — The Hebrew 'dovroth' carries a double meaning of both 'rafts/vessels' and 'speech/utterances,' creating a deliberate wordplay that connects floating vessels with spoken words. This alternate translation captures both meanings more explicitly.

[B] Or: "one who is rising from mortal illness" — While the literal translation refers to ascending from earthly depths, contextually this may refer to a person rising from serious illness rather than someone already deceased, as the passage mentions 'the mouth of the ill one' later.

[1] The Hebrew 'dovroth' (דוברות) means 'rafts' but also relates to 'speech,' creating a pun that connects flotation devices with spoken words.

[2] This poetic passage depicts the soul's journey after death, using the feminine Shulamite figure from Song of Songs to represent the soul returning to celestial realms.

[i] Refers to burial societies (chevra kadisha) whose members perform the final acts of kindness for the dead, considered the purest form of kindness since it cannot be reciprocated.

[ii] A reference to the female figure in Song of Songs, here used as a metaphor for the soul. The name derives from 'shalem' (complete/perfect), suggesting the soul's completion through its return to God.

[iii] Alludes to Psalm 68:18, referring to celestial realms with divine chariots and angelic hosts that receive the ascending soul.

[iv] Acronym for 'Garden of Eden' (גן עדן), the traditional Jewish concept of paradise where righteous souls dwell after death.

בו בחר ה׳ ופתחו לי שערי צדק
1080 אבא בם אודה יה. וקודם פטירתי
מן גוייתי זאת אודה עלי פשעי
לה׳ אדאג ואתמרמר ואבכה
על חטאתי ולמירוק ותיקון
צחנת מעשי הנה מצדיק עלי דין
1085 שמים ומקבל עלי דין ויסורי
המיתה באהבה וברצון הגומל
לחייבים טובות הוא יגמלני כל
טוב סלה וירחמני מן העבודה
הקשה אשר עבדו בי מעני וכזאת
1090 אוחילה ישועתה לה׳. ויטהרו
ויצרפו העומדים עליו עשתונות
לבו בדבריהם ובמעשיהם
ובקריצותיהם וברמיזותיהם עד
כי יהיה פונה למסלה העולה
1095 בית אל באמור לו ולנשמתו אל
תשכחי עמך ובית אביך[i] הרגעי
ודומי להם האנק דום וסבול
כי בזאת תנצל מפח מן האדמה
ותדבקי בה׳ כאשר ידבק האזור
1100 אל מתני איש. שובי שולמית עדי
וכי חנון ורחום הוא אף ארך
אפים ורב חסד כי מעודך גמל
עליך ויחזיקוהו באמונת תורתנו
ונבואת משה אדוננו ושאר י״ג
1105 עקרי הדת[ii] וביחוד שמע ישראל
ובשכמ״ל[iii] ובה׳ הוא האלהים
ובאנא בכח[iv] ובפסוקי שרפים
עומדים ממעל לו וקרא זא״ז

the Lord has chosen, and open for me the gates of righteousness that I may enter them and praise the Lord."

"And before my departure from this body, I will confess my transgressions to the Lord. I will worry, 1070R
become bitter, and weep over my sins. For the purification and correction of the stench of my deeds,[1] behold, I justify the heavenly judgment upon myself and accept with love and willingness the judgment and sufferings of death. May He who bestows good- 1075R
ness upon the guilty bestow all goodness upon me forever and have mercy upon me from the hard labor that my afflictions have worked upon me. Thus do I hope for salvation from the Lord."

Those standing by will purify and refine his 1080R
thoughts[A] through their words, actions, winks, and hints[B] until he turns toward the highway that ascends to the House of God, as they say to him and his soul: "Do not forget your people and your father's house. Be calm and silent before them, 1085R
sigh silently and endure, for in this way you will be saved from the snare in the ground[2] and cling to the Lord as a belt clings to a man's waist. Return, O Shulamite, for He is gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and abundant in kindness, for He has 1090R
always been good to you."

They will strengthen him in the faith of our Torah and the prophecy of Moses our master and the other thirteen principles of faith, and especially with "Hear O Israel" and "Blessed be the name of His glori- 1095R

[A] Or: "the tumult of his heart" — 'Eshtonot' in biblical Hebrew (as in Psalm 146:4) refers to thoughts but carries connotations of troubled or agitated thinking. This translation better captures the emotional turmoil of someone facing death.

[B] Or: "through gestures and subtle signals" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the practical nature of nonverbal communication methods used by those attending the dying person, who may be unable to understand or respond to speech.

[1] This vivid language reflects the Jewish concept that sin creates spiritual impurity, often metaphorically described as a foul odor that requires cleansing.

[2] This may refer to both the grave and to spiritual traps that might impede the soul's ascent, reflecting the belief that the period immediately after death involves spiritual dangers.

[i] Alludes to Psalm 45:11, 'Forget your people and your father's house,' but inverted to encourage the soul to remember its earthly connections even as it ascends.

[ii] The thirteen principles of faith formulated by Maimonides, considered fundamental tenets of Judaism.

[iii] Acronym for 'Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever' (ברוך שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד), recited after the first verse of the Shema.

[iv] The opening words of a mystical prayer attributed to the 1st century sage Rabbi Nehunya ben HaKanah, containing a 42-letter divine name.

ואמר ובשיר של פגעים[i] עם
מזמור ה׳ מה רבו צרי עד לה׳
הישועה עד כי תצא נשמתו
בטהרה ועשה תעשה לו כנפים
וכנשר תעוף השמים והוא
יכוננה עליון בזכות מעשיה
ועוד כי אתה תפרד מתוך
רנה של תורה וקדושה ודברי
שיחה שבין קודשא בריך הוא
ושכינתיה[ii] ואם יזכה לקיים
אפילו בשעת מיתה תורה
נשמתיה תסק באינון אורחין
ושבילין דאינון באורייתא
כדפי׳ רשב״י[iii] בפ׳ וישלח
דף קפ״ב ע״ב וכמה ככרין
דנרד למארי דיכי כי לשון
חכמים ברכה לשון חכמים עושר
לשון חכמים מרפא כדאמרו
בכתובות פ׳ י״ב ובזה נעביד
ליה מלתא דתהוי ליה חיותא
לעולם הבא:[iv]

ous kingdom forever and ever" and "The Lord, He is God" and "Please, with the strength..." and the verses of "Seraphim standing above Him, each calling to the other, saying..." and with the "Song of Afflictions" along with the psalm "O Lord, how numerous are my adversaries" until "Salvation belongs to the Lord"—until his soul departs in purity and wings are made for it, and like an eagle it soars to the heavens, and the Most High will establish it through the merit of its deeds. 1100R 1105R

Moreover, you will depart amidst the joy of Torah and holiness and the conversations between the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence. And if one merits to fulfill Torah even at the moment of death, his soul will ascend through those paths and trails that are in the Torah,[1] as Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai explained in Parshat Vayishlach, page 182b. And how many talents of nard for the Master who has purified you![2] For the language of the sages is blessing, the language of the sages is wealth, the language of the sages is healing, as they said in Ketubot, chapter 12. And in this way, we will do something for him that will become life for him in the World to Come.[A] 1110R 1115R

[A] Or: "we will create for him a spiritual reality that will sustain his eternal life" — This Aramaic

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that Torah study creates spiritual pathways through which the soul can ascend to higher realms, especially relevant at the moment of death.

[2] This poetic expression, using the valuable perfume 'nard' from Song of Songs, suggests that the words of Torah sages are precious spiritual treasures that benefit the departing soul.

[i] Rabbinic name for Psalm 91, traditionally recited for protection against harmful forces, especially relevant during the vulnerable time of death.

[ii] An Aramaic phrase from the Zohar referring to God and His Divine Presence, representing the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity in Kabbalistic thought.

[iii] Acronym for Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, the 2nd century sage traditionally considered the author of the Zohar, the primary text of Jewish mysticism.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Opening Section — This passage reveals the core purpose of Ma'avar Yabok as a practical guide for those attending to the dying, providing them with specific verses and prayers to recite that will help the departing soul transition to the afterlife. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Vayishlach — The author cites this Zohar passage to establish the kabbalistic foundation for his claim that souls who engage with Torah even at death will ascend through spiritual pathways created by Torah study. | Cf. Talmud, Ketubot — The author cites this Talmudic source to emphasize that the words of Torah sages provide blessing, wealth, and healing, reinforcing why reciting their teachings benefits the dying. | Cf. Song of Songs — The author transforms the Shulamite figure from Song of Songs into a representation of the human soul returning to its divine source, reframing the erotic biblical poetry into a mystical description of the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The author includes Psalm 91, traditionally recited for protection against harmful forces, as one of the key protective prayers to be recited for the dying person, reflecting the belief that the moment of death involves spiritual dangers requiring divine protection. | Cf. Psalm 3 — The author prescribes Psalm 3 as part of the liturgy for the dying, using its theme of divine deliverance from numerous enemies as a metaphor for the soul's deliverance from physical suffering and spiritual adversaries at death.

ואמרו בשכר משרתי ה׳ ועושי רצונו בעה״ז במדרש שה״ש דף כ״ג ע״ב כל העוסק בתורה בעה״ז אף בעה״ב אין מניחין אותו לישן אלא מוליכין אותו לבית מדרשו של שם ושל עבר ושל אברהם יצחק ויעקב ושל משה ואהרן ועד היכן עד ועשית לך שם גדול כשם הגדולים אשר בארץ. ואמרו בפ׳ חלק זמר כל יום זמר בכל יום כי ר״ע היה אומר הוי מסדר תלמודך אע״פ שמסודר בפיך בזמר והוא יגרום לך שתהיה לעה״ב בשמחה ובשירים. עוד שם דף כ״ו על פסוק ששים המה מלכות אלו ס׳ חבורות של צדיקים שיושבין בג״ע תחת עץ החיים ועוסקים בתורה. ושמנים פילגשים אלו שמנים חבורות בינוניות שיושבו׳ ועוסקות בתור׳ חונה להם תחת עץ החיים ועלמו׳ אין מספר אין קץ שם להלמידי׳ וכלם דורשים מטעם א׳ מהלכה א׳ מג״ש א׳ מק״ו א׳ ואשרי הזוכה להרביץ תורה ברבים לשמה ומעמיד תלמידי׳ הגונים בעה״ז. עוד אמרו שם שכל תורה שאדם לומד בעה״ז הבל הוא לפני תורה שבעה״ב[i] וזה לפי שעתה אין עסקנו אלא בכלי חמדה

Concerning the reward for those who serve God and perform His will in this world, the Midrash Song of Songs (page 23b) states: "Whoever engages in Torah study in this world will not be permitted to sleep even in the World to Come. Instead, they will be led to the study houses of Shem, Eber, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Moses, and Aaron. To what extent? Until 'you will make for yourself a great name,[1] like the name of the great ones who are in the earth.'"

They also said in Chapter Chelek: "Sing daily, recite daily," for Rabbi Akiva would say: "Review your learning even though it is already organized in your mouth, like a song, and this will cause you to be in the World to Come with joy and songs."

Further, on page 26, regarding the verse "There are sixty queens,"[2] these represent sixty groups of righteous ones who sit in the Garden of Eden beneath the Tree of Life studying Torah. "And eighty concubines" refers to eighty intermediate groups who dwell and engage in Torah beneath the Tree of Life. "And maidens without number" indicates there is no limit to the number of students there. All of them expound from the same reasoning, from the same law, from the same gezera shava (textual analogy),[3] from the same kal vachomer (logical deduction).[4] How fortunate is one who merits to spread Torah among the public[A] for its own sake and establishes worthy students in this world.

They further stated that all the Torah a person learns in this world is mere vapor compared to the Torah of the World to Come.[B] This is because now

phrase uses the term 'milta' which can mean 'word/thing/matter' but in kabbalistic contexts often refers to creating spiritual realities through speech. This translation better captures the mystical concept of how reciting sacred texts creates eternal spiritual sustenance.

[A] Or: "to teach Torah to the masses" — The phrase 'להרביץ תורה' is an idiom specifically referring to teaching Torah rather than just spreading it. This alternate translation better captures the active educational aspect implied in the Hebrew.

[B] Or: "is like a breath compared to the Torah of the World to Come" — The Hebrew word 'hevel' (הבל) literally means 'breath' or 'vapor' and is used metaphorically to indicate something transitory or of minimal substance compared to something greater. Either translation conveys the meaning, but 'breath' might be more literally accurate.

[1] This is a reference to God's promise to Abraham in Genesis 12:2.

[2] This refers to Song of Songs 6:8, which reads: 'There are sixty queens and eighty concubines, and maidens without number.'

[3] Gezera shava is one of the traditional hermeneutical principles in rabbinic interpretation, where similar words in different contexts are used to derive legal principles.

[4] Kal vachomer is a form of a fortiori argument in rabbinic literature, reasoning from a lesser case to a greater one.

[i] This doesn't mean that Torah study in this world is worthless, but rather that the wisdom accessible in this world is limited compared to what will be revealed in the World to Come.

ובנובלות חכמה של מעלה[i] אך שם יעסקו הצדיקים בחמדה גנוזה ובחכמה של מעלה לא בנובלות. ברם זאת התורה היא השער לה׳ וממנה יזכו הצדיקים לחמדה גנוזה כמשל המדרש[ii]

our engagement is only with "vessels of desire" and with the "fallen fruit" of the supernal wisdom, but there the righteous will engage with the "hidden treasure" and with the supernal wisdom itself, not merely its fallen fruit. Nevertheless, this Torah is the gateway to the Lord, and through it the righteous will merit the hidden treasure, as in the parable of the Midrash.

ממי שהיה מכבד למלך שהולך במדבר בכלכלה של גרוגרות וחבית של יין אמר המלך כבוד גדול הוא זה וכו׳.[iii] ובפ׳ חלק[iv] אמרו כל המשחיר פניו בעה״ז על דברי תורה[v] הקב״ה מבהיק זיוו לעה״ב וכן כל המרעיב עצמו עליהם בעה״ז הקב״ה משביעו לעה״ב שנאמר ירויון מדשן ביתך[vi] וגו׳ ושם א״ר חייא על פסוק עשיתי לי ברכות מים כי הדרשות נקראים כן שנמשכים בלמודים רבים והשגות שונות בכל עת שאדם הוגה בהם בפני רבים נעשה

It is like one who honors a king traveling in the desert[1] with a basket of dried figs and a cask of wine; the king says, "This is a great honor," etc. And in chapter Chelek, they said: "Whoever blackens his face in this world for the sake of Torah study,[2] the Holy One, blessed be He, makes his radiance shine in the World to Come." Similarly, "Whoever starves himself for Torah in this world, the Holy One, blessed be He, will satisfy him in the World to Come," as it is said, "They shall be abundantly satisfied with the fatness of Your house," etc. And there, Rabbi Chiya said regarding the verse, "I made myself pools of water": This refers to expositions, which are called thus because they flow with many teachings and various insights.[3] Whenever a person contemplates them be-

[1]This opens with a parable from the Talmud about how even modest offerings are valued in contexts of need, establishing the theme that seemingly small acts of Torah study or charity have great spiritual value.

[2]This metaphorical expression refers to suffering or self-denial for Torah study, including the willingness to appear foolish by asking questions or the physical hardship of studying in difficult conditions.

[3]The text uses water imagery throughout—flowing teachings, pools, springs—creating an extended metaphor comparing Torah wisdom to water that nourishes and sustains, culminating in the 'waters of supernal Eden.'

[i]The term 'noblot chochma' (fallen fruit of wisdom) comes from rabbinic literature (Bereishit Rabbah 17:5), where it is stated that the Torah of this world is merely the fallen fruit of the supernal wisdom.

[ii]Cf. Song of Songs Rabbah — The text uses this midrash to demonstrate the hierarchical structure of Torah scholars in the afterlife, showing that merit gained through Torah study in this world creates different levels of status in the World to Come. | Cf. Talmud Bavli — This reference establishes the importance of consistent Torah study as preparation for spiritual rewards in the afterlife, emphasizing that the habit of regular review transforms learning into something melodious and joyful.

[iii]This is a truncated quote from a Talmudic passage in Sanhedrin where a king traveling in the desert appreciates even modest offerings (dried figs and wine). The author uses 'etc.' (וכו׳) since the audience would know the full passage.

[iv]Refers to 'Perek Chelek,' the eleventh chapter of Tractate Sanhedrin, which discusses the World to Come and is a major source for discussions of reward and punishment in rabbinic literature.

[v]Literally 'whoever blackens his face in this world for words of Torah,' a Talmudic expression describing one who suffers or struggles in Torah study, either through self-denial or the social embarrassment of asking questions.

[vi]From Psalm 36:9, 'They shall be abundantly satisfied with the fatness of Your house.' The full verse continues, 'and You shall make them drink from the river of Your delights,' which connects to the later reference to 'the waters of supernal Eden.'

כמעין נובע כל א׳ כפי השגת
ידו ואמרו במדרש משלי כל מי
שהוא מפיק בדברי תורה ומלמד
ברבים אף אני בעת רצון מפיק
לו רצון. ובודאי כי יפיקו רצון
מאת ה׳ מן השמים כל א׳ בחברי
בני גומלי חסדים או שאר הקהל
המתוועדים שם בבית החולה
להקבלת פני שכינה דקדמא
ואתיא[i] וכוונתם ג״כ לגמול
חסדים טובים מאוצר העליון
על המוטל על ערש דוי ולעורר
רחמים גדולים מרעוא עילאה
על הדין נשמתא בואבתא אשר
בסופה ובסערה דרכה[ii] והם
שם צמודים ומיוחדים באחדותא
וחיזותא להכניסה תחת כנפי
השכינה ולהשעין אותה תחת
צל עץ החיים בזה ועל כל
א׳ מהם שאחר אורך ימים
ושנות חיים יתלוו עם נשמתם
אלף אלפי אלפים רבבות קדש
ובעת פטירתם במראה הבזק
ינוצצו[iii] ויושיבם לנצח ויגבהו
כי צדקתם זו תעמוד להם לעד
ומשפעת מי נחל עדן עליון
יוערך לפניהם שלחן ולחם
פנים לפני ה׳ תמיד ישביעם

fore many people, he becomes like a flowing spring, each according to his understanding. And they said in the Midrash Mishlei: "Whoever produces words of Torah and teaches them publicly, I too, at a favorable time, will grant him his desire." 1175R

And surely, they will obtain favor from the Lord in heaven[A]—each one among the members of the charitable society or others from the congregation who gather in the house of the sick person to welcome the Divine Presence that precedes and arrives.[1] Their intention is also to bestow good kindnesses from the supernal treasury upon the one lying on the sickbed and to awaken great mercies from the supreme will for this suffering soul whose path is in storm and tempest.[2] They are united there, joined together in unity and vision[B] to bring it under the wings of the Divine Presence and to shelter it under the shadow of the Tree of Life. 1180R 1185R 1190R

And for each one of them, after long days and years of life, thousands upon thousands of holy multitudes will accompany their souls,[3] and at the time of their departure, they will flash like lightning, and He will seat them forever and exalt them. For this righteousness of theirs will stand for them eternally, and from the flow of the waters of the supernal Eden, a table will be set before them. The Lord will continually satisfy them with the showbread, and they shall eat and have plenty, 1195R 1200R

[A] Or: "they will elicit favor from the Lord in heaven" — The Hebrew verb 'יפיקו' carries the sense of drawing out or eliciting, which more precisely captures the active role these individuals play in generating divine favor through their actions.

[B] Or: "bound together in unified purpose and shared vision" — This rendering better captures the Aramaic terms 'באחדותא וחיזותא' which emphasize both the purposeful unity and the shared spiritual perception of those gathered around the sick person.

[1] This references a Talmudic teaching that the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) arrives at the bedside of the sick before the visitor does, elevating the act of visiting the sick from mere human kindness to a divine encounter.

[2] This poetic description of the suffering soul uses biblical imagery of divine power manifesting in storms, suggesting that the sick person's suffering has spiritual significance rather than being random misfortune.

[3] The text describes the eschatological reward for those who perform acts of kindness, promising divine accompaniment in the afterlife similar to how they accompanied the sick in this world—a spiritual application of the 'measure for measure' principle.

[i] A reference to the Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 127a) that when one visits the sick, the Divine Presence arrives before them. The Aramaic phrase 'דקדמא ואתיא' means 'that precedes and arrives.'

[ii] An allusion to Nahum 1:3, 'The Lord has His way in the whirlwind and in the storm.' Here applied to the soul's difficult journey during illness.

[iii] An allusion to Ezekiel 1:14, 'And the living creatures ran and returned as the appearance of a flash of lightning,' which describes the angels in Ezekiel's vision. Here it refers to the souls of the righteous.

ויאכלו ויותירו כמו שהם כמה
פעמים השביעו נפש שוקקה ונפש
רעבה מלאו טוב ואין נווב אלא
תורה[i] כן יתן ה׳ את רוחו עליהם
כי אינו מקפח שכר כל בריה
ומדה כנגד מדה לא בטלה [ii]

just as they many times satisfied the yearning soul and filled the hungry soul with goodness[A]—and "goodness" refers only to Torah.[1] Thus, may the Lord put His spirit upon them, for He does not withhold the reward of any creature, and the principle of "measure for measure" has not been abolished. 1205R

וגם הם ינוסו יגון ואנחה ולא
יפחדו מיום צרה ותוכחה כי
יעתור להם ויצילם. עוד יחשב
קטורת ויהיה לריח ניחוח
כוונתם בצרכי הנפטר כאשר בא
במאמרים אלו מתוקן ומקובל
על כל פרט ופרט וזה באמת א׳
מהכוונות הראשונות שכוונתי
בהם כאשר הרואה יראה בעיניו
ובלבבו יבין מחמת הקדמות
שיבואו מפורשות בזה הרבה
יותר ממה שכתוב בתוכם:
וזה יהיה פרי מצותם שהקרן
יהיה שמור וקיים וצפון להם

And they too shall flee from sorrow and sighing, and shall not fear the day of trouble and rebuke, for He will entreat for them and save them. Moreover, their intention in attending to the needs of the deceased, as presented in these discourses—properly arranged and accepted in every detail—shall be considered as incense and shall be a pleasing fragrance.[2] This was truly one of the primary intentions I had in mind, as the reader will see with his eyes and understand in his heart from the introductions that will be explained in much greater detail than what is written within them. 1210R 1215R 1220R

This shall be the fruit of their commandment: the principal shall be preserved, enduring, and stored for

[A] Or: "quenched the thirsting soul and satisfied the hungry soul with goodness" — The Hebrew 'שוקקה' can also carry connotations of thirst rather than general yearning, which would create a more parallel structure with 'hungry' in the second part of the phrase and maintain the water imagery present throughout the passage.

[1] This interpretive formula (known as 'ein...ela') is a rabbinic hermeneutic method that restricts the meaning of a term to a specific interpretation. Here, it connects the 'goodness' with which they filled others to Torah, which they will receive as reward.

[2] This imagery draws on the biblical concept of sacrifices being a 'pleasing fragrance' (ריח ניחוח) to God. Here, proper care for the deceased is metaphorically elevated to the status of Temple offerings, suggesting it has similar spiritual efficacy.

[i] A rabbinic interpretive formula stating 'good' (טוב) refers specifically to Torah, based on Proverbs 4:2, 'For I give you good doctrine; do not forsake my Torah.' There appears to be a scribal error in the text, writing 'נווב' instead of 'טוב' (good).

[ii] Cf. Sanhedrin 100a — The opening reference to honoring a king with figs and wine is quoted from this Talmudic passage, which discusses how even modest offerings can be greatly valued when given in circumstances of need. | Cf. Sanhedrin 100a — The statements about 'blackening one's face' and 'starving oneself' for Torah study are direct quotes from this Talmudic passage, which describes the rewards awaiting those who sacrifice physical comfort for spiritual growth. | Cf. Psalms 36:9 — The verse 'They shall be abundantly satisfied with the fatness of Your house' is quoted to demonstrate the divine reward awaiting those who dedicate themselves to Torah study. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 2:6 — The reference to 'I made myself pools of water' alludes to this verse from Ecclesiastes, which Rabbi Chiya interprets metaphorically as referring to Torah expositions. | Cf. Zohar — The language about the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), unity, and the Tree of Life reflects Zoharic terminology and concepts about the soul's journey and divine emanations. | Cf. Berakhot 63b — The principle of 'measure for measure' (midah k'neged midah) is a fundamental concept in rabbinic thought about divine justice, referenced here to explain how those who care for others will receive similar care.

לעה״ב [i] ויזכו כל א׳ מהם שאחד
מאותם הנקרא חרכים שהוא
בהיכל השלישי מצד הקדושה
לצד דרום [ii] הממונה על אותם
שעושים חסד עם המתים יחקוק
דיוקנו למעלה לזכותו לעה״ב
כאשר הבטיח שם רשב״י בפרשה
פקודי. [iii] וכי ישכבו יזכו
שיצאו לקראתם הנשמות שלוו
אותם בדברי קדושה על דרך
שאמר ר׳ יוחנן במס׳ תענית כי
שכיבנא ר׳ הושעיא נפיק לוייתי
דמתריצנא מתני׳ כוותיה [iv] וכן
אמר הרמב״ן בקמא פ׳ בתרא כי
מובטח לו שהרי״ף יצא לקראתו
במותו [v] וכן נאמר למהרר״י
קאר״ו כי הרמב״ם יצא לקראתו
עם שאר צדיקים [vi] שעשה להם
נחת רוח בעה״ז וכל העושה
מצוה זו כמאמרה אין מבשרין
אותו בשורות רעות. ואמרו
במדרש רות על פסוק כאשר
עשיתם עם המתים שנטפלתם

them in the World to Come.[A] Each of them will merit that one of those called "lattices," which is in the third chamber on the holy southern side,[1] who is appointed over those who perform acts of kindness with the dead, will engrave his image above to merit him in the World to Come, as Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai promised in the section of Pekudei. 1225R

And when they lie down to sleep [die], they will merit that the souls they accompanied with holy words will come forth to meet them, as Rabbi Yochanan said in the Tractate Ta'anit: "When I die, Rabbi Hoshaya will come out to accompany me because I explained the Mishnah according to his interpretation."[2] Similarly, Ramban said in the last chapter of Bava Kamma that he was assured that the Rif would come to meet him at his death. And it was also said to Rabbi Joseph Karo that Maimonides would come to meet him, along with other righteous ones for whom he had provided spiritual satisfaction in this world. And whoever performs this commandment as prescribed will not be given bad tidings. 1230R 1235R 1240R

And they said in the Midrash Ruth regarding the 1245R

[A] Or: "This shall be the fruit of their mitzvah: the principal amount shall be safeguarded, maintained, and reserved for them in the World to Come" — This alternate preserves the financial metaphor more explicitly with 'principal amount' and uses the untranslated term 'mitzvah' which might better convey the specifically Jewish religious concept involved.

[1] I've translated this complex kabbalistic reference directly. The 'lattices' refers to openings between spiritual worlds, and the reference to the 'third chamber' and 'southern side' reflects the detailed mystical geography of heavenly realms in Jewish mysticism.

[2] This reflects the rabbinic belief that souls of the righteous welcome others in the afterlife, particularly those who propagated their teachings. The translation preserves the casual, conversational tone of Rabbi Yochanan's statement.

[i] This employs traditional rabbinic terminology for spiritual reward, drawing on the Mishnaic concept that certain mitzvot provide 'fruit' in this world while the 'principal' (קרן) is preserved for the World to Come.

[ii] This refers to kabbalistic cosmology where the heavenly realm is organized into chambers (היכלות). The term 'lattices' (חרכים) alludes to Song of Songs 2:9 ('peering through the lattices') and in mystical literature refers to openings between spiritual worlds.

[iii] This refers to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, the traditional author of the Zohar, and specifically to the section of the Zohar that comments on the Torah portion Pekudei (Exodus 38:21-40:38), which contains extensive discussions of celestial realms.

[iv] This is a reference to Talmud Ta'anit 9a, where Rabbi Yochanan expresses his expectation that Rabbi Hoshaya would come to welcome him in the afterlife because Rabbi Yochanan frequently explained Mishnayot according to Rabbi Hoshaya's interpretation.

[v] This refers to a tradition about Nachmanides (Ramban) stating that Rabbi Isaac Alfasi (the Rif) would greet him in the afterlife. The 'last chapter of Bava Kamma' refers to the final chapter of that Talmudic tractate.

[vi] This refers to a tradition about Rabbi Joseph Karo, author of the Shulchan Aruch, that Maimonides (Rambam) would come to greet him in the afterlife along with other righteous figures whose works he had studied and explained.

בתפלותיהם. ולפי דרושנו
יתבאר כי העומדים על הנפטר
בשיחה קדושה בעת כי רוחו
ונשמתו אל אל יאסף הם ודאי
בזכות אמריהם כי נעמו פורשים
עליו בגד ארגמן וכורכים בתוכו
נשמתו[i] ולבלתי תתבהל ותדחה
מהחצונים המזדמנים שם עם
מלאכא דמותא[ii] ומהם באים
להאחז בגופו שהיה נרתק של
קדושה. ושם אמר בש״ר זעירא
מגילה זו אין בה לא טומאה
ולא טהרה[iii] לא איסור ולא
היתר ולמה נכתבה ללמוד
כמה שכר טוב לגומלי חסדים.
ובמדרש קהלת א״ר יהודה
כל הכופר בג״ח כאלו כופר
בתורה.[iv] ובפסוק והחי יתן אל
לבו זהו חי העולמים[v] שהוא
משלם שכר לכל נש על פסיעה
שעושה בגמילות חסדים.
ובמדרש תהלים דף מ״ד ע״א
א״ר יהושע החסד מן העולם
ועד העולם אבל הצדקה עד ג׳

verse "as you have done with the dead"—that you attended to their prayers.[1] According to our interpretation, it will be explained that those who stand by the deceased with holy conversation at the time when his spirit and soul are gathered to God—certainly by 1250R
the merit of their pleasant words—spread a purple garment over him and wrap his soul within it[A] so that it will not be frightened and pushed away by the external forces that gather there with the Angel of Death,[2] some of which come to cling to his body 1255R
which was a sheath of holiness.

And there Rabbi Ze'ira said in the name of Resh Lakish: "This scroll [of Ruth] contains neither impurity nor purity, neither prohibition nor permission—why then was it written? To teach how great is the 1260R
reward for those who perform acts of kindness." And in the Midrash Kohelet, Rabbi Judah said:[3] "Whoever denies acts of loving-kindness is as if he denies the Torah." And regarding the verse "and the living shall take it to heart"—this refers to the Eter- 1265R
nal Living One who rewards a person for every step taken in performing acts of loving-kindness. And in the Midrash Tehillim, page 44a, Rabbi Joshua said: "Kindness extends from one world to the next, but

[A] Or: "spread a royal purple garment over him and enfold his soul within it" — This alternate translation emphasizes the royal associations of the purple garment (suggesting dignity and honor) and uses 'enfold' which might better capture the protective, embracing quality of the action described.

[1] This is interpreting the phrase 'נטפלתם בתפלותיהם' which literally means 'you attached yourselves to their prayers' or 'you busied yourselves with their prayers.' It refers to praying for the deceased or attending to prayers related to burial rituals.

[2] The term 'external forces' (החיצונים) refers to negative spiritual entities in kabbalistic thought. The passage describes a spiritual battle at the moment of death, with proper ritual creating protection for the departing soul.

[3] Throughout this passage, the author is building a theological argument about the importance of attending to the deceased by citing multiple authoritative sources from rabbinic literature, showing how this act of kindness carries eternal spiritual rewards.

[i] The imagery of wrapping the soul in a purple garment draws on both royal symbolism (purple being associated with royalty) and kabbalistic concepts of 'garments of the soul' that protect it during its journey through spiritual realms.

[ii] In kabbalistic terminology, 'chitzonim' (חיצונים/external ones) refers to negative spiritual forces. 'Malakha d'mota' is Aramaic for 'the angel of death.' This reflects the belief that both the angel of death and negative forces are present at the time of death.

[iii] This quote about the Book of Ruth is from the Midrash Ruth Rabbah 2:14, highlighting that despite lacking legal content about ritual purity and impurity, Ruth teaches about the value of kindness.

[iv] ג״ח is an abbreviation for 'gemilut chasadim' (גמילות חסדים), acts of loving-kindness. This teaching emphasizes that denying the importance of kindness is equivalent to denying the Torah itself.

[v] This creatively reinterprets Ecclesiastes 7:2 ('the living will take it to heart') by suggesting that 'the living' refers to God (חי העולמים/the Eternal Living One), who rewards acts of kindness.

דורות[i] [ii] charity only for three generations."[A] 1270R

ובמזמור קי״ח על פסוק פתחו
לי שערי צדק[iii] לעה״ב אומרים
לו לאדם מה מלאכתך והוא
אומר מאכיל רעבים הייתי והם
א״ל[iv] זה השער של מאכיל
רעבים הוא הכנס בו וכן למגדלי
יתומים ולגומלי חסדים וכן
לכל המצות. הנה ראינו עטרת
זהב גדולה[v] אשר יסד המלך
מלכו של עולם לגומלי חסדים
טובים בעה״ז עם החיים ועם

And in Psalm 118, regarding the verse "Open for me the gates of righteousness,"[B] [it is taught that] in the World to Come, they ask a person, "What was your occupation?"[1] And he replies, "I fed the hungry," and they tell him, "This is the gate for those who fed the hungry—enter through it." And likewise for those who raised orphans, those who performed acts of kindness, and so for all commandments. Behold, we have seen the great crown of gold which the King, Sovereign of the Universe, has established[C] for those who perform acts of kindness in this world with 1275R 1280R

[A] Or: "Kindness [endures] from world to world, but charity [only lasts] for three generations" — This alternate translation more literally renders the Hebrew phrase 'from world to world' (מן העולם ועד העולם), which has the connotation of eternal duration rather than specifically referring to this world and the next.

[B] Or: "Open for me the gates of righteousness in the World to Come" — This alternate translation incorporates 'leh'olam haba' (לעה״ב) directly into the verse, making explicit that the gates mentioned are in the afterlife, rather than treating it as a separate phrase. However, the original translation is preferred because it maintains the biblical verse's wording, with the World to Come reference functioning as a contextual specification.

[C] Or: "the magnificent golden crown which the King, Sovereign of the Universe, has prepared" — This alternate translation uses 'magnificent' for 'גדולה' and 'prepared' for 'יסד', which might better convey the sense of divine preparation of rewards. However, the original translation more literally represents the Hebrew text.

[1] The question uses 'occupation' (מלאכתך) in a spiritual sense, referring not to one's profession but to one's primary spiritual activity or focus during life.

[i] This teaching contrasts chesed (kindness) with tzedakah (charity), suggesting that the spiritual rewards of acts of kindness extend eternally ('from world to world'), while the merit of financial charity extends only for three generations.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Pekudei — The author is citing the Zohar as an authoritative source to support his claim about the specific spiritual rewards awaiting those who properly care for the dead. This reinforces the text's kabbalistic framework while providing doctrinal support for the practices he advocates. | Cf. Talmud, Ta'anit 9a — By citing this Talmudic passage, the author establishes a prestigious precedent for the concept that souls of the righteous will greet those who honored their teachings. This forms part of his argument about the reciprocal spiritual relationship between the living and the deceased. | Cf. Book of Ruth — The author uses this midrashic interpretation to support his emphasis on prayer and proper speech around the dying. This interpretation transforms Ruth from a narrative about loyalty to a source text for proper ritual practices surrounding death. | Cf. Song of Songs 2:9 — The term 'lattices' (חרכים) is drawn from this biblical verse but reinterpreted in kabbalistic literature to represent openings between spiritual worlds. This exemplifies how the author incorporates biblical imagery into a mystical cosmological framework. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:2 — The author creatively reinterprets this verse by suggesting that 'the living' refers to God Himself (the Eternal Living One), who rewards acts of kindness. This demonstrates the author's approach of finding mystical meanings in straightforward biblical texts.

[iii] This quote from Psalm 118:19 is reinterpreted here in an eschatological context, with the 'gates of righteousness' referring to entrances to the World to Come, rather than to the Temple as in the original context.

[iv] An abbreviation for 'אומרים לו' (they say to him).

[v] The metaphor of a 'great crown of gold' draws on royal imagery to describe divine reward, suggesting that those who perform acts of kindness are treated with royal honor in the afterlife.

המתים. מצינו על פסוק כי חסד
חפצתי ולא זבח[i] א״ר יוחנן לר׳
יהושע שאמר לו אוי לנו על
הבית שנחרב מקום שמתכפרין
בו אבותינו וא״ל בני אל ירע
לך שיש לנו כפרה אחת שהיא
כמותה[ii] ואיזה זה גמ״ח: [iii]

both the living and the dead.[1] We find regarding the verse "For I desire kindness and not sacrifice" that Rabbi Yochanan said to Rabbi Yehoshua, who had lamented, "Woe to us for the destruction of the Temple, the place where our ancestors achieved atonement." He replied to him, "My son, do not be distressed, for we have one form of atonement that is equivalent to it[A]—and what is that? Acts of loving-kindness."[2]

ששו בני מעי גם ששו בהיותו
זה ימים מועטים במנטיבה
המהוללה[iv] תוך אותה קהלה
קדושה עיר ואם בקהלות
איטליאה. ודאי שמלבד שכל
העדה כלם קדושים ובה כליל
במעלות עטרת היחס צבי
הדת והארץ האירה מכבוד

My heart rejoiced greatly[B] during the few days I spent in the praised Mantua,[C] within that holy community, a mother city among the communities of Italy.[3] Certainly, besides the fact that the entire congregation is holy and encompasses all levels of distinguished lineage, the splendor of the faith, and the land shines with the honor of the sages who sit in judgment—may God protect them collectively and

[A] Or: "for we have another means of atonement that serves the same purpose" — This alternate translation emphasizes the functional equivalence of loving-kindness to Temple sacrifice, rather than just their comparability. However, the original translation more accurately reflects the Hebrew wording.

[B] Or: "My innermost being exulted, yes exulted" — The Hebrew 'בני מעי' literally refers to 'the children of my innards' or 'my internal organs,' a Biblical Hebrew idiom for one's deepest feelings. This more literal translation preserves the poetic Hebrew expression.

[C] Or: "in the lauded Mantua" — The term 'המהוללה' can be translated as 'lauded' which might better convey the formal praise being given to the city.

[1] This phrase is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as it emphasizes that true loving-kindness extends beyond the living to proper treatment of the dying and deceased, a central theme of the book.

[2] The Hebrew term גמ״ח (gemilut chasadim) encompasses a broader range of actions than the English 'kindness' suggests, including material assistance, personal involvement, and spiritual support for both the living and the dead.

[3] The phrase 'עיר ואם' (literally 'city and mother') is a biblical expression (2 Samuel 20:19) referring to an important city that serves as a center or capital for surrounding communities.

[i] This quote from Hosea 6:6 becomes particularly significant after the Temple's destruction, as it provides biblical support for the idea that kindness can replace sacrifice as a means of atonement.

[ii] This teaching about acts of kindness serving as a substitute for Temple sacrifice is especially meaningful in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on proper treatment of the dying and deceased as forms of loving-kindness.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 118:19 — The verse 'Open for me the gates of righteousness' is being interpreted mystically as referring to the entrance to the World to Come, with different gates corresponding to different virtuous acts performed in life. | Cf. Hosea 6:6 — The verse 'For I desire kindness and not sacrifice' is used to establish that acts of loving-kindness can substitute for Temple sacrifices as a means of atonement. | Cf. Avot de-Rabbi Natan — The dialogue between Rabbi Yochanan and Rabbi Yehoshua resembles teachings in Avot de-Rabbi Natan about substitutes for Temple atonement. | Cf. Talmud Bavli — The Talmudic discussion that acts of loving-kindness are superior to sacrifice because they can be performed with both one's person and one's money, and benefit both the living and the dead.

[iv] Mantua was an important center of Jewish learning and culture in northern Italy during the Renaissance and early modern period. The city had a significant Jewish population and was known for its rabbinical scholarship.

החכמים היושבים על מדין
ישמרם ה׳ בכלל ובפרט ויעלם
גם עלה. ראיתי שם בפרט
במה מתוקנים מעשיהם וכמה
מיושרים אורחותיהם בבנין
חצרות מתיהם ובני חבורות
גמילות חסדים משם.[i] גם שיש
מהם הרבה דלא תנו משנה
וגמרא והלכתא לאו כ״ע דינא
גמירי[ii] מ״מ בנפש נכספה
מתעסקים במצוה רבה דא. ואגב
אורחי שם שמעתי בשמם כי זה
כמה ימים אשר נפשם התאוה
תאוה שאחד מתוך העדה יקים
לסדר לפניהם סדרים ערוכים
להפגין קולם ברנה ותפלה
בעת יציאת נשמה.[iii] ולהיות
כי אל אלהי הרוחות לכל בשר
לא ימנע טוב להולכים בתמים
ורצון יראיו יעשה סבב וגלגל כי
דבר זה נפתח בגדולים ונסתיים
בקטון הכמות והאיכות הלא
אנכי המך באלפי אהרן ברכיה
ממודינ״א:[v iv]

individually and elevate them ever higher. I particularly observed there how proper their deeds are 1300R
and how upright their ways in the construction of their cemetery courts[1] and in the charitable burial societies there. Even though many of them have not studied Mishnah and Talmud, and not everyone is learned in the law, nevertheless they engage in this 1305R
great commandment with longing souls.[2] While visiting there, I heard in their name that for some time their souls had greatly desired that someone from the congregation would establish and arrange for them orderly services to raise their voices in joyful prayer 1310R
at the time of a soul's departure. And since the God of the spirits of all flesh does not withhold good from those who walk in integrity, and He fulfills the desire of those who fear Him, He arranged and brought it about that this matter which began with the great 1315R
ones concluded with one small in both quantity and quality[A]—none other than myself, the lowly among thousands, Aaron Berechia of Modena.[3]

[A] Or: "that this matter which was initiated by the great ones ended up being completed by one insignificant in both stature and ability" — This alternate translation better captures the extreme self-deprecation the author is expressing, which is a common rhetorical device in rabbinic literature.

[1] The 'construction of cemetery courts' refers to the physical infrastructure for burial grounds, which in Jewish tradition required proper organization and maintenance as a sign of respect for the dead.

[2] The phrase 'בנפש נכספה' indicates a deep spiritual yearning or desire, suggesting that even those without formal religious education participated in burial societies out of genuine spiritual motivation rather than mere social obligation.

[3] The author signs his name with extreme humility, referring to himself as 'המך באלפי' (the lowly among thousands), which is a common rhetorical device in rabbinic literature where authors present themselves as unworthy while undertaking important religious work.

[i] The 'charitable burial societies' (chevra kadisha) were organizations responsible for preparing bodies for burial according to Jewish law and tradition. These societies were considered especially holy because they performed acts of kindness (washing, dressing, and burying the dead) that could never be reciprocated.

[ii] The author notes that many members of these burial societies were not formally educated in Mishnah and Talmud. This suggests that participation in burial societies was open to ordinary members of the community, not just scholars, which was typical of Italian Jewish communities.

[iii] The community desired organized prayer services specifically for the moment of death. In Jewish tradition, proper prayers and practices at this moment were considered crucial for helping the soul transition to the afterlife.

[iv] Aaron Berechia of Modena (c. 1550-1639) was an Italian rabbi and kabbalist, author of Ma'avar Yabok. He should not be confused with his more famous contemporary Leon (Judah Aryeh) Modena, though both were from the same city.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok introduction — This passage parallels the book's introduction, as both explain

וכשמעם כי תאות לבם ניתן להם
לפחות בקצת לא בחנו מבטן
מי יצאו הדברים ומגברא דלית
ליה דיעה קא בעו[i] ותמיד אל
דמי להם ברוח חן ותחנונים. אך
זה היום שקוינו מצאנו ראינו
מעשיך יזכנו לבקר בהיכלי
מלך ולעשות כוונים למלאכת
ג״ח[ii] מהרה חושה מעשיך וערכך
אשר ערכת שים נא לפנינו
השמן הוא אם רזה ואם כמאכל
ב״ד[iii] או כסעודת שלמה אשור
הייא אשור הייא[iv] כי בטחנו
מעמל נפשך נשבע שובע שמחות
אנו ואתה לאורך ימים ומה יעשה
יחיד בין הרבים והגם שעדיין
לא הבשילו אשכולות יריעותי
והיה בעיני תבשיל שלא בשל
כל צרכו וכל עוד שמצטמק יפה

When they heard that their heart's desire had been granted to them, at least in part, they did not examine from whose mind these words came, and they sought from a man who has no knowledge. Yet they constantly entreated me with a spirit of grace and supplication.[A] But this is the day we have hoped for[1]—we have found and seen Your works! May He grant us the privilege to visit the King's palaces and to establish proper intentions for the work of acts of kindness.[2] Quickly, hasten Your works! The arrangement that You have arranged, please place before us[B]—whether it is rich or lean, whether like a court's meal or Solomon's feast. Proceed! Proceed! For we trust that from your soul's labor we shall be satisfied with an abundance of joy, both we and you, for length of days.

And what can an individual do among the many? Even though the clusters of my writings have not yet ripened,[3] and in my eyes it seemed like a dish not

[A] Or: "And they gave me no rest, continually appealing with a spirit of grace and supplication" — The phrase 'אל דמי להם' could also be understood as 'they gave no rest' or 'they were not silent to me,' which might better capture the sense of persistent entreaty. This alternate translation emphasizes the continuous nature of their requests.

[B] Or: "And Your evaluation which You have assessed, please set before us" — The Hebrew 'ערך' can mean both 'arrangement' and 'evaluation/assessment,' and the context could support either reading. This alternate translation emphasizes the evaluative aspect rather than the organizational one.

[1] The author shifts between pronouns, addressing both God directly and speaking of the community collectively, creating a complex rhetorical style that blends prayer with personal narrative.

[2] This refers specifically to the holy work of caring for the dying and deceased, which is the central concern of Ma'avar Yabok. The 'proper intentions' mentioned refer to the kabbalistic concept that ritual actions must be performed with specific spiritual intentions to be fully effective.

[3] The author employs agricultural metaphors to express his sense that his work is not yet fully matured or perfected, reflecting his humility about the text's quality.

the author's humble acceptance of a task that seemed beyond his abilities. The author consistently presents himself as unworthy but divinely guided to undertake important spiritual work for his community. | Cf. Psalm 51:10 — The author's phrase "ששו בני מעי" (my innards rejoiced) echoes biblical expressions of deep emotional and spiritual feelings, similar to how Psalm 51 locates spiritual experience in the heart. This suggests the author experienced his time in Mantua as a profound spiritual event, not merely a pleasant visit. | Cf. Zohar on death rituals — The author's mention of 'raising voices in joyful prayer at the time of a soul's departure' alludes to kabbalistic understandings (as found in the Zohar) about how proper prayer at death facilitates the soul's journey. This frames these rituals within mystical Jewish tradition rather than merely as community customs.

[i] This includes an Aramaic phrase 'ומגברא דלית ליה דיעה קא בעו' meaning 'and they sought from a man who has no knowledge,' reflecting the author's self-deprecating style.

[ii] G"CH is an abbreviation for 'gemilut chasadim' (acts of kindness), specifically referring to the charitable work of caring for the dying and deceased, which is the central focus of Ma'avar Yabok.

[iii] B"D is an abbreviation for 'beit din' (court), referring to a simple, moderate meal that would be appropriate for a court setting, contrasted with the lavish feast of King Solomon.

[iv] This appears to be an emphatic repetition, possibly of Aramaic origin, encouraging proceeding forward with the work despite its perceived imperfections.

לו כי אינו דומה השונה פרקו
וכו׳ [i] מ״מ [ii] לכבוד שמים ולזכות
לנפשי העלובה וגם להיות שייף
ועייל שייף ונפיק [iii] להפיק רצון
בני חבורה זו שומרי משמרת
הקדש אשר פקודת כל אדם
יפקוד מהם [iv] ובראשה השרידי
עם [v] וקצת מיחידי סגולה [vi] אשר
כל המבטל רצונו מפני רצונם
לא חלי ולא מרגיש [vii] כי נחלה זו
שפרה להם [viii] למען טובה וזאת
היתה סבה שנדבה רוחם אותם
להיות נמנים עם בני החבורה
ושיקרא עליהם שמם לכבוד
ולתפארת להדריכם ולקרבם אל
מלאכת שמים זו יוסיף ה׳ עליהם
עוז ותעצומות ויתענגו על רוב
שלום באורך ימים ושנות חיים
ואין מחריד: [x] [ix]

fully cooked—and the longer it simmers, the better it becomes, for one who reviews his lesson once cannot be compared to one who reviews it multiple times— 1340R
nevertheless, for the honor of Heaven and to benefit my wretched soul, and also to be one who enters and exits smoothly to fulfill the desire of the members of this society, guardians of the holy watch,[1] from whom the final summons will come to all men. At 1345R
their head are the remnants of the people and some unique treasured individuals, for whoever nullifies his will before their will neither feels pain nor suffers, because this inheritance has been beautified for them for their benefit. And this was the reason their spirit 1350R
moved them to be counted among the members of the society, that their name should be proclaimed over them for honor and glory, to guide them and bring them near to this heavenly work.[2] May the Lord add to them strength and might, and may they 1355R
delight in abundant peace, with length of days and years of life, with none to make them afraid.

[1] This refers to members of the burial society (Chevra Kadisha) who care for the dying and prepare bodies for burial, considered one of the most sacred duties in Jewish communal life.

[2] The author sees his writing as serving both practical and spiritual purposes: providing guidance for proper ritual performance while also elevating the spiritual status of those who perform these sacred duties.

[i] This references a Talmudic saying (Hagigah 9b): 'One who reviews his learning 100 times cannot be compared to one who reviews it 101 times.' The author uses 'etc.' (וכו׳) because this was a well-known saying to his audience.

[ii] Abbreviation for 'mikol makom' (nevertheless).

[iii] An Aramaic expression from the Talmud (Yevamot 103b) literally meaning 'rubs in, rubs out,' describing someone who moves smoothly and humbly between places or roles without causing friction or drawing attention.

[iv] This alludes to Numbers 16:29, referring to death as 'the final summons of all men,' appropriate in a text dealing with care for the dying.

[v] This refers to 'the remnants of the people,' an expression from Isaiah 1:9 and Joel 3:5 that refers to the righteous few who remain faithful.

[vi] This term refers to unique, treasured individuals of special spiritual or moral worth, commonly used in rabbinic literature to describe people of exceptional virtue.

[vii] An Aramaic expression meaning 'neither feels pain nor suffers,' used to describe someone who experiences no discomfort or hardship from a particular situation.

[viii] This alludes to Psalms 16:6, 'The lines have fallen for me in pleasant places; indeed, I have a beautiful inheritance,' describing the spiritual benefits that come to those who serve in this holy society.

[ix] This concluding phrase comes from Leviticus 26:6, describing the blessing of peace without fear, a common closing formula in blessings and prayers.

[x] Cf. Talmud Hagigah 9b — The author uses this reference to justify why his work might benefit from further refinement while also suggesting that he is presenting it despite its imperfections, for the sake of heaven and to benefit the community. | Cf. Numbers 16:29 — By referencing this passage about death, the author reminds readers of the universal mortality that makes Ma'avar Yabok's guidance on death rituals relevant to everyone, especially those in the burial society who will face this 'final summons.' | Cf. Leviticus 26:6 — The author concludes with this biblical blessing formula to express his wish that those who perform the sacred duties of caring for the dying and dead will be rewarded with divine protection and peace.

ע״פ הדברים האלה כרתי
אתם ברית והבטחתים להוציא
מחשבתי הטוב׳ מן הכח אל
הפועל ואמרתי חזו דאתאי חזו
דאתאי דכל שיהויי מצו״ה לא
משהינן ושיתין רהוטי ארהוט עד
כי אבין להתחיל המלאכה שהוא
יותר מחצי הכל ואשירה לה׳ כי
גמר עלי ואלהים הוא יודע וגם
עם ישראל ידע כי לא יכולתי
לשום עיני על מלאכתי זאת אפי׳
לעשות לה המהדור׳ קמא כאשר
היה עם לבבי ונכרין דברי אמת
מתוך לשון הספר כי הוא כאשר
ידבר איש אל רעהו ולא כיפי
תלאי למלתיה ובכיר ולקיש
כחדא יצק כפי מה שבא פריי
בעטי בפעם ראשונה שאז לא
היה אפשר לו לילך אחר שיחה
נאה רק לכוין הדברים שיהיו
נאמרים באמת ע״פ ד״ת וד״ס.
ויהי מה בטחתי בחסד אל כי לא
יהיה בהם דבר בלתי מתקבל
לדעת כל דברי רז״ל ואשתומא
לא קאמינא כי לזה דרכי שמרתי
ולא הטיתי ימין ושמאל אחר
איזה דעות מהמתפלספים כי
הרבה מדרכיהם רחקה נפשי
ולא ירד כבודי עמהם ולאו וא״ו
אאופתא כתבי כי דעת שפתי
חז״ל ברור מללו וכל דורך בהם

Based on these words, I made a covenant with them and promised to bring my good intentions from potential to action. I declared, "See that I have come, 1360R
see that I have come,"[A] for we do not delay the fulfillment of commandments. I ran sixty runs[B] until I understood how to begin the work, which is more than half the battle.[1] I will sing to the Lord for He has dealt bountifully with me.[2] God knows, and Is- 1365R
rael too knows, that I could not set my eyes on this work of mine, even to create a first draft as I had intended. The words of truth are recognizable in the language of the book, for it is as one person speaking to another, without ornamentation of words. I 1370R
combined early and late sources as one,[C] according to what my pen produced at first writing, when it was not possible to pursue elegant discourse but only to ensure that the words would be spoken truthfully according to the words of Torah and rabbinic teach- 1375R
ings.

Whatever happens, I trust in God's kindness that there will be nothing in them unacceptable to all the words of our Sages of blessed memory. I do not say things I do not understand,[D] for I have kept to my 1380R
path and have not turned right or left after any opinions of the philosophers, for my soul has distanced itself from many of their ways, and my honor shall not join with them. I have not written the letter vav on a prescription tablet,[E] for the knowledge from 1385R
the lips of our Sages speaks clearly, and anyone who walks in their ways will know peace, if only he is worthy of it.

[A] Or: "Behold I have arrived, behold I have arrived" — This Aramaic phrase could be translated more dramatically to capture the declarative nature of the announcement.

[B] Or: "I hastened with sixty rushes" — This Aramaic expression describes intense effort and speed, and this alternate translation might better capture the metaphorical sense of urgency and exertion.

[C] Or: "not like one who embellishes his words with decorations. I poured out early and late teachings together" — This is a difficult phrase with metaphorical language about literary style, and this alternate captures the imagery of 'pouring out' (יצק) teachings without artificial embellishment.

[D] Or: "I do not speak of things beyond my comprehension" — This Aramaic phrase expresses the author's commitment to intellectual honesty, and this alternative might better capture his determination to stay within the bounds of what he truly comprehends.

[E] Or: "I have not written even a single letter vav on a prescription tablet" — This is an idiomatic expression likely referring to writing something without proper authority or knowledge. The alternate emphasizes the minimal nature of the letter vav to strengthen the metaphor.

[1] The Hebrew phrase "יותר מחצי הכל" (more than half of everything) references the Jewish principle that beginning a mitzvah is the hardest part and constitutes more than half the work.

[2] This phrase echoes Psalm 13:6, "I will sing unto the LORD, because he hath dealt bountifully with me," connecting the author's gratitude to biblical expressions of thanksgiving.

ידע שלום ואם רק הוא ממנו. כי
יש לאדם לחשוב דרכו ולצרף
דבריו קודם שיוציאם מפיו כי
תנא דבי אליהו קב״ה ישב ודרש
ובחן וצרף כל התורה כלה
וכל דבר שהוא מד״ת דורשו
חוקרו וצורפו ברמ״ח פעמים
נגד רמ״ח אברים שבאדם ואח״כ
מוציאו מפיו וקבעו בתורה
שנא׳ אמרות ה׳ אמרות טהורות
ואמרו במדרש מלמד שלמד
הקב״ה עצה ודעת למשה ונתנם
לו באמת וכתב לו אותם באמת
והודיעם לו באמת כדי שילך הוא
וישמיעם לישראל באמת וזהו
להודיעך קושט אמרי אמת. וכ׳
החכם בעל העקדה בשער כ״ה
כי חוייב לשכל להכחיש קצת
משפטיו ודיניו מפני ההוראות
האלהיות הנאצלות עליו. ואנו
מקבלי תורת ה׳ אין אנו צריכים
להקדמות שהוצרכו לחכמי
הפלוסופיא לבאר מציאות ה׳
ית׳ אחדותו ופשיטותו שזכרן
הרב המורה בתחלת חלק ב׳
כי הראנו ה׳ אלהינו את כבודו
ואת גדלו במתן תורה בהר
סיני. עוד לאפס הפנאי הרבה
הגהות שהוספתי בגליון מדי
יום ביום כאשר היה שם אלהים
בפי. קצת מהם לא הושמו
כ״כ מכוונים במקום אשר היה
ראוי להם מלבד שכמה דברים
שהיו שייכים למלאכה זו שמדי
יום מתחדשים ובאים לא באו
בכתובים יהא רעוא דנזכה
ונחיה דאולי בלא נדר עדיין
נחוה דעת אי״ה לזכותנו כפי

A person should consider his path and refine his words before uttering them, for the School of Elijah taught that the Holy One, blessed be He, sat and expounded, examined and refined the entire Torah.[1] Everything that is part of Torah's words, He expounds, investigates, and refines 248 times, corresponding to the 248 limbs in a person, and only afterward does He bring it forth from His mouth and establish it in the Torah, as it is said, "The words of the Lord are pure words." And they said in the Midrash: This teaches that the Holy One, blessed be He, taught Moses counsel and knowledge, and gave them to him in truth, wrote them for him in truth, and made them known to him in truth, so that he might go and announce them to Israel in truth. This is the meaning of "to make you know the certainty of truthful words."

The Sage, author of the Akedah, wrote in Gate 25 that the intellect is obligated to deny some of its judgments[2] and decisions because of the divine instructions emanating upon it. And we, recipients of God's Torah, do not need the premises required by the philosophers[3] to explain the existence, unity, and simplicity of God, which the Rambam mentioned at the beginning of Part II [of the Guide for the Perplexed], for the Lord our God has shown us His glory and His greatness at the giving of the Torah at Mount Sinai.

Furthermore, due to lack of time, many corrections that I added in the margin day by day, as God's name was in my mouth, some of them were not placed as precisely in the place where they should have been. Besides, many things relevant to this work that are renewed and emerge daily did not make it into writing. May it be His will that we merit to live, and perhaps, without making a vow,[4] we shall still express our thoughts, God willing, to merit according to the thoughts of our heart to learn and to

[1] The author describes God's meticulous process of refining Torah teachings 248 times (corresponding to the traditional number of limbs in the human body) before revealing them, establishing a divine model of careful composition that the author tries to emulate.

[2] This references the Jewish philosophical position that human reason must sometimes yield to divine revelation, particularly when they appear to conflict. The author cites Rabbi Isaac Arama's 'Sefer HaAkedah' to support this view.

[3] The author is specifically contrasting his mystical approach with that of Maimonides' 'Guide for the Perplexed,' suggesting that philosophical proofs for God's existence are unnecessary for those who accept the direct revelation at Sinai.

[4] The phrase "בלא נדר" (without a vow) is a traditional rabbinic qualifier when expressing an intention to do something in the future, avoiding the serious religious implications of making and potentially breaking a formal vow.

עשתנות לבנו ללמוד וללמד.
ועתה במטו מנכון רבנן קשישי
או את רעי עמיתי אשר כנפשי
הקורא באהבה יריעות מגילתי
אל נא תשימו אשם לנפשי אם
באולי תמצאו איזה ענייניים
בלתי מקושרים כל כך יפה
באיזה מקומות כי הכל לשם
שמים מותר ושרי ומתון מתון ד׳
מאה זוזי שוייא ואם תמצאו בו
איזה שגיאה במטותא מינייכו לא
תחלוניה רק יורוני וילמדוני
כי תורה היא וללמוד אני צריך
ואעשה אזני כאפרכסת לשמוע
דברי חכמי׳ וחידותם ואם
האריכותי מעניתי בהקדמתי זאת
שלא כדרכי בוונתי בזה לעורר
הלבבות ולא תימרון יוד קרת
קא חזינא הכא כי לא כן עשיתי
בדברי הספר כי אין בו שפת יתר
רק כפי הצורך להבנת הדברים
במיעוט אמרים: [i]

teach.

And now, I implore you, venerable rabbis, or you, my colleagues who are like my own soul, who read with love the sheets of my scroll, please do not place blame on me if perhaps you find some matters not so beautifully connected in some places, for everything is for the sake of Heaven, permitted and allowed, and "patience, patience is worth four hundred zuz." And if you find any error in it, I beg you, do not profane it,[1] but rather teach and instruct me, for it is Torah, and I need to learn. I will make my ear like a funnel to hear the words of the sages and their riddles. And if I have lengthened my response in this introduction, which is not my usual way, my intention was to awaken hearts. Do not say, "We see a city dweller here,"[2] for I have not done so in the words of the book itself, as it contains no excess language, only what is necessary for understanding the matters with few words.

1430R 1435R 1440R 1445R

ואתה דוד נאמן [ii] למען חסדך
תתרצה לשום עיניך על מאמרות

And you, faithful David,[A] for the sake of your kindness, please be willing to set your eyes upon these dis-

[A] Or: "And you, trustworthy reader" — While the text directly addresses someone named David, this could be understood as a rhetorical device addressing any faithful reader. This alternative broadens the address to include all readers while maintaining the sense of trustworthiness.

[1] The phrase "לא תחלוניה" is an Aramaic request not to profane or dismiss the work, despite any errors it might contain. Instead, the author humbly asks for instruction and correction.

[2] The phrase "יוד קרת קא חזינא הכא" is an Aramaic expression suggesting someone is putting on urban sophistication or pretentiousness. The author is asking readers not to accuse him of being pretentious in his introduction.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author implicitly positions his work within the Zoharic tradition by contrasting his adherence to 'words of Torah and rabbinic teachings' (ד״ת ודו״ס) with philosophical approaches. This reflects the Zohar's own stance privileging mystical revelation over rational philosophy. | Cf. Maimonides' Guide for the Perplexed — The author is situating his own work in relation to the rationalist tradition represented by Maimonides. While not rejecting Maimonides outright, he suggests that direct revelation (at Sinai) obviates the need for philosophical proofs of God's existence, unity and simplicity, highlighting his more mystical approach. | Cf. Sefer HaAkedah (Book of the Binding) — This reference shows the author's strategic use of philosophical sources when they support the primacy of revelation over reason, a key principle in kabbalistic thought. He is building a case for the superiority of traditional rabbinic wisdom over philosophical speculation. | Cf. Tana d'bei Eliyahu — This reference establishes divine perfectionism as a model for the author's own careful approach to composition. By drawing this parallel, he suggests that his own writing process, while imperfect, aims to emulate divine thoroughness in preparing sacred texts. | Cf. Proverbs 22:21 — This biblical reference serves as a cornerstone for the author's approach to authorship—positioning himself as a transmitter of divine truth rather than an originator of wisdom, consistent with kabbalistic attitudes toward revelation and tradition.

[ii] The author is addressing an individual named David, whom he describes as "faithful." This could be a specific reader or a generic address to the reader.

אלו או כלם או מקצתם קרא
נא בפיך תחלה דברי הקדמתי
זאת ואל יכבד עליך כפל איזה
דברים[i] אם חפצת צדקני והנני
מבטיחך כי לא אשנה עוד באורך
ההצעות ופעם אחת ישמעון
מילי ולא אשגה בשפת יתר ועל
דא אפקוהו לר׳ ירמיה מבי
מדרשא שהיה מטריח בדברים
כדאי׳ בב״ב פ״ב[ii] ואל נא יקחך
לבך מהם בהיות כי בסקירת
איזה פרקים יראה בעיניך כי
דרכיהם גבהו מעט מהפשט[iii] כי
הן מיעוטא דמיעוטא[iv] ואם
לא תתפלא לעצמך כמנהג
אותם שרמות להם חכמות עד
שבעבור זה עוברים על ופן
יסורו מלבבך[v] אנכי היודע ועד
שרובם ככולם הם מובנים לכל
קורא בה בישוב דעתו והרי
שלחן והרי פת והרי בשר לפני

courses,[1] either all of them or some of them. Please
first read aloud the words of this introduction of
mine, and do not be troubled by the repetition of cer- 1450R
tain matters if you desire to justify me.[A] I promise
you that I will not again be lengthy in my presenta-
tions, and my words will be heard just once, and I
will not err with excessive language. It was for this
reason that they expelled Rabbi Yirmiyah from the 1455R
study hall,[2] as he was burdensome with his words, as
mentioned in Bava Batra, chapter 2. Please do not
let your heart be distracted from them, even though
in reviewing some chapters it may appear to you that
their ways are slightly elevated above the plain mean- 1460R
ing,[3] for they are but a minority of a minority.[4] And
if you do not marvel at yourself, as is the habit of
those who consider themselves wise to the point that
they transgress the warning "lest they depart from
your heart,"[5] I know and testify that almost all of 1465R
them are understandable to anyone who reads them
with a settled mind. Behold, the table is set, and
here is bread, and here is meat before all the young

[A] Or: "if you wish to give me a fair hearing" — The Hebrew 'tzadkeni' literally means 'justify me' but carries the connotation of giving someone a fair hearing or the benefit of the doubt. This alternative better captures the author's request for a charitable reading.

[1] The Hebrew 'ma'amarot' (discourses) refers to the sections of Ma'avar Yabok. The author is humbly asking the reader to consider reading at least some portions of the book if not the entire work.

[2] This refers to a Talmudic story (Bava Batra 23b) where Rabbi Yirmiyah was temporarily expelled from the study hall for asking excessively technical questions. The author uses this as a cautionary tale about being too verbose or complicated.

[3] The author acknowledges that some passages employ mystical or philosophical interpretations beyond the literal meaning (peshat). This is a typical apologetic stance in kabbalistic works, acknowledging that some content might be challenging while reassuring readers of its overall accessibility.

[4] Translation of the Aramaic legal expression 'mi'uta d'mi'uta,' emphasizing that difficult passages are rare exceptions. The author is reassuring readers that most of the text is accessible to ordinary readers.

[5] This is a reference to Deuteronomy 4:9, which warns against forgetting divine teachings. The author is cautioning against the intellectual arrogance that might lead readers to dismiss teachings they don't immediately understand.

[i] The author acknowledges that there may be some repetition in his work and asks the reader not to be bothered by it.

[ii] The author references a Talmudic story from Bava Batra where Rabbi Yirmiyah was expelled from the study hall for asking overly burdensome questions, using this as a cautionary tale about being excessively verbose.

[iii] The author acknowledges that some passages in his work go beyond the simple literal meaning (peshat) into more mystical or philosophical interpretations, but assures the reader these are relatively few.

[iv] An Aramaic legal term meaning "a minority of a minority"—the author is emphasizing that difficult passages are very rare exceptions in his work.

[v] A reference to Deuteronomy 4:9, warning against forgetting divine teachings. The author is cautioning against intellectual arrogance that leads to disregarding important teachings.

כל נערים יושבי שורה.[i][ii]

men seated in a row.[A]

וקודם אשים דברתי לקץ אליכם
אישים אקרא מעם חבירי גומלי
חסדים שבכל מדינה ומדינה
ולכל הגלוים עמהם לשמור
משמרת הקדש שימו נא לבבכם
והמו אזניכם ותהיה לטוטפות
בין עיניכם זאת העצה היעוצה
מדברי הגמרא והפוסקים
חדשים גם ישנים ובפרט מס׳
הזוהר בהרבה מקומות ועל
כלם בפ׳ ויחי ובשלח ופקודי
והאזינו שדעת שפתותיהם ברור
מללו לכל הפקידים לשמור
משמרת החולה שנוטה למיתה
והטוב שברופאים אומר שסביב
יבעתוהו בלהות החולי בר
מינן: ושהוא פרונקא דמלאכא
דמותא ואם יאמרו לאדם מית
חברך אשר הגם שמכבר התוודה
בנהוג ביום קרוב עת פקודתו
חובה על כל המטפלים בו אחיו
ומיודעיו ובפרט לבני החבורה
באחד המיוחד מהם במתק שפתיו

Before I conclude my words, I call upon you, people of distinction, from among my colleagues in charitable societies in every province and all those who join with them to maintain the sacred vigil. Direct your hearts, incline your ears, and let this be as frontlets between your eyes—this counsel drawn from the words of the Talmud and later authorities, both recent and ancient, particularly from the Zohar in many places, especially in the portions of Vayechi, Beshalach, Pekudei, and Ha'azinu. Their utterances clearly instructed all those appointed to keep watch over the sick person[1] who inclines toward death, when the best of physicians says that terrors of illness surround and frighten him, Heaven forbid, and that he is the messenger of the Angel of Death.

If they tell a person, "Your friend is dying," even though he has already confessed as customary on a day close to his appointed time, it is the duty of all who attend to him—his brothers, his acquaintances, and especially members of the burial society—that one distinguished among them should, with sweetness of speech, inform the dying person that this decree comes by the watchers' determination,[B] for

[A] Or: "Behold, I have prepared a feast of knowledge—table, bread, and meat—accessible even to students sitting in the basic rows" — This metaphorical expression compares the book to a feast of varying levels of sophistication (table, bread, meat) that is accessible even to beginning students. The alternative makes the metaphorical meaning more explicit while preserving the original imagery.

[B] Or: "by the decree of the celestial guardians" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the mystical nature of the 'watchers' (עירין) as celestial beings rather than human observers. The term comes from Daniel 4:14 where it refers specifically to angelic beings who announce divine decrees.

[1] The author is addressing members of the chevra kadisha (burial society) and others who care for the dying, providing specific instructions for their sacred duty.

[i] A metaphorical expression comparing his book to a feast that is accessible even to young students. The table, bread, and meat represent different levels of learning that are available to all readers.

[ii] Cf. Deuteronomy 4:9 — The author uses this biblical reference to caution against intellectual arrogance. Just as the Israelites were warned not to forget what they had seen and learned, the author warns readers not to dismiss teachings they find difficult, suggesting that even challenging mystical passages contain important wisdom that should be retained. | Cf. Talmud Bava Batra — The author references this Talmudic story (Bava Batra 23b) as a self-deprecating cautionary tale. Rabbi Yirmiyah was temporarily expelled for asking questions that were considered too pedantic or burdensome. The author acknowledges the risk of being similarly verbose or technical and promises to avoid this pitfall, showing awareness of the need for clarity and directness in presenting mystical teachings. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok introduction — The author refers to his earlier introduction, showing that this passage comes from a later part of the prefatory material. This self-referential structure was common in rabbinic works, where authors would often include multiple introductory sections addressing different aspects of the work or different audiences. The author seems to be guiding readers to approach the text in a specific order, starting with the general introduction before engaging with the main content.

יודיע אליו כי בגזרת עירין
1505 פתגמא ואין הקב״ה עושה דבר
אא״כ נמלך בפמליא של מעלה:
ובמאמר קדישין שאול נשאל
למתיבתא דרקיעא ושיום המות
הוא יום לידת נפשו וחפשיותה
1510 ממאסרה מבית חשך ושחמות
הוא קדרינותא דצפרא שבעד
כוכבים יחתום והשמש יוצא על
הארץ ובבח האור הקטן להפיע
המאור הגדול שמש ומגן ה׳
1515 אלהים ושאשרי המוציא נשמתו
בטהרה במשחל ביניתא מחלבא
ואיערב שמשא ואידכי יומא ועל
זאת יתפלל כל חסיד לעת מצא
זו מיתה לקיים אז ואהבת את
1520 ה׳ אלהיך בכל לבבך ובכל
נפשך וראיה מר״ע שבזה תדבק
נפשו ותעלה במחשבה הטהורה
מקום שמן משחת קדש והחכמה
תחיה את בעליה חיי עד. ע״כ
1525 יקדש עצמו כשרפים ויאסוף
כל עשתונות לבו וכל רגלי
סבותיו ומאורעיו אל המטה
העליונה ולתקונה ולכבודה
ושנשמתו עתה בהעלותה תהיה
1530 במדרגת השובין ליחד בין
קב״ה ושכינתיה באורה עם
כל חבילות מצותיה העולים
עמה מימינה ומשמאלה. ובזה
יגרום רנה למלאכין דשכינתא
1535 ומלאכין דקב״ה כי יקדישו זה
לזה ויעריצו זה לזה ויקראו
זה לזה ויביעו וידברו באהבה
באחוה בכח האי נשמתא קדישתא
הנקשרים בה כשלהבת קשורה

the Holy One, blessed be He, does nothing without consulting His heavenly court. By the decree of the holy ones, his soul is being summoned to the heavenly academy, and that the day of death is the birth day of his soul[1] and its liberation from imprisonment in the house of darkness. Death is like the darkness before dawn[A] when He seals up the stars and the sun rises upon the earth, and through the power of the small light, the great luminary shines forth—"For the Lord God is a sun and shield." Fortunate is one who surrenders his soul in purity, like drawing a fish from milk[B] when the sun sets and the day is purified. Concerning this, every pious person prays at the proper time—which is death—to fulfill "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul." Evidence comes from Rabbi Akiva, for in this way his soul cleaved and ascended in pure thought to the place of holy anointing oil,[2] and "wisdom preserves the life of its possessor" for eternity. 1495R 1500R 1505R 1510R

Therefore, one should sanctify himself like the seraphim and gather all his thoughts and all the causes and events of his life toward the supernal bed, for its rectification and honor. His soul, as it ascends, will be at the level of attendant unifying the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence in light, together with all the bundles of commandments that ascend with it,[3] to its right and left. This will cause rejoicing among the angels of the Divine Presence and the angels of the Holy One, blessed be He, for they will sanctify one another, revere one another, call to one another, and speak with love and brotherhood through the power of this holy soul to which they are bound like a flame bound to a coal: "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord of hosts," etc. Many songs of light ascend with the holy soul on its upward journey.[C] The heavenly altar is built, and 1515R 1520R 1525R

[A] Or: "Death is the darkness preceding dawn" — This more literal translation of the Aramaic phrase 'קדרינותא דצפרא' preserves the poetic metaphor that compares death to the darkest part of night just before sunrise, emphasizing that spiritual illumination follows the darkness of death.

[B] Or: "like slipping a fish out of milk" — The Aramaic verb 'משחל' conveys a sense of easy extraction or slipping out. This alternative better captures the intended image of a painless, smooth separation of the soul from the body that ideally occurs at death.

[C] Or: "And how many illuminated hymns ascend with the holy soul along its path of eleva-

[1] This positive reframing of death is central to the book's approach, presenting death not as an end but as a spiritual birth or liberation from physical constraints.

[2] A mystical reference to the soul's ascent to the highest divine realms, using the imagery of the sacred anointing oil (שמן משחת קדש) which was used to consecrate priests for divine service.

[3] In Jewish mysticism, the mitzvot (commandments) a person performs create spiritual entities that accompany the soul after death, serving as protective escorts and evidence of merit.

בגחלת קדוש קדוש קדוש ה׳ צבאות וגו׳ ושכמה שירי אורות עולים עם הנשמה קדושה דרך עלייתה. ומזבח העליון בנוי ומיכאל שר הגדול עומד ומקריב נשמות הצדיקים כדכתבו התוס׳ בסוף פ״ב דמנחות ודברים כדומה לזה הידועים למחצדי חקלא קדישא וכל עוד חוסיו בו יודיעוהו גזרת מלכו לטוב לו ולנשמתו למען יהיה פיו ולבו שוים לשוב בודוי בלבו ובפיו על כל חט׳ ואשמה כי אם לא עכשיו אימתי ועל הכל שיקבל עליו דין שמים באהבה והיה שדי בצריו כדאמרו במס׳ ברכות פ״ג על המשתף שם שמים בצערו ושחשוב הוא לאתפוסי אדרא וטיבותא איהי לגביה ובתומתו יחזיק עכ״פ ולא ירפנה כי כל המאמץ עצמו בתפלה מלמטה אין לו צרים מלמעלה ואשרי המקיים מצוה אחת סמוך למיתתו כי בזה יקרא עובד מאהבה וזהו נסיון לכל האדם ואשרי המוסר נפשו בכוונתו פעמים בכל יום על יחוד שמו בפסוק שמע ישראל כי אז בשעת יציאת נשמתו יהיו לו עוזרים הרבה ליחד שמו הגדול. ואל נא יעברו על בל תונו איש את עמיתו כי ודאי זו אונאה רבה אשר מנפש עד בשר יכלה ויהפכו בנבלתא אם יהפכו במילייהו ואע״פ שמצר עכשיו שמח הוא לאחר זמן ויהיה ריב לחולה עם הנצבים עליו אם לא כן יעשו. לא כמנהג הנשים הקלות

Michael, the great prince, stands and offers the souls of the righteous, as the Tosafot wrote at the end of the second chapter of Menachot, and similar matters known to the reapers of the holy field.[1]

While they still look to him, they should inform him of his Sovereign's decree for his own good and for his soul's benefit, so that his mouth and heart may be aligned in returning through confession in his heart and with his mouth for every sin and transgression, for if not now, when? Above all, he should accept heaven's judgment with love and "God will be with his adversaries," as they said in Tractate Berakhot, chapter 3, concerning one who joins God's name with his suffering, that he is worthy to be a representative of the community,[A] and it is good for him. He should maintain his integrity in any case and not let it go, for anyone who exerts himself in prayer from below has no adversaries from above. Fortunate is one who fulfills a single commandment near his death,[2] for in this he will be called one who serves out of love, and this is the test for every person. Fortunate is one who surrenders his soul with proper intention twice daily to unify His Name through the verse "Hear, O Israel," for then at the time his soul departs, he will have many helpers to unify His great Name.

They should not transgress "You shall not wrong one another," for this is surely a great wronging that consumes from soul to flesh, and they will be dealing with a corpse if they are deceitful in their words. Even though he is distressed now, he will be happy later, and there will be strife between the sick person and those standing around him if they do not act properly. Not like the custom of frivolous women, not like those of Shakhnetziv mentioned in Moed Katan, nor like those spiritually deficient men who say to him, "You will surely live, you will not die," which is like striking him with a hundred lashes with a bundle

1530R 1535R 1540R 1545R 1550R 1555R 1560R 1565R

tion" — This translation better preserves the mystical nuance where 'שירי אורות' refers not just to songs about light but to spiritual emanations or hymns that are themselves illuminated or light-bearing, accompanying the soul in its ascent.

[A] Or: "to be taken as a leader of the assembly" — The Aramaic term 'אדרא' in mystical contexts often refers specifically to a mystical assembly or circle, while 'לאתפוסי' has connotations of being seized or taken up. This translation better captures the mystical context where accepting suffering with faith makes one worthy of spiritual leadership.

[1] מחצדי חקלא קדישא is an Aramaic expression from the Zohar referring to accomplished mystics who 'harvest' spiritual truths, indicating that certain mystical concepts are fully understood only by advanced kabbalists.

[2] The text emphasizes the special merit of performing mitzvot when approaching death, as these are considered done purely for their spiritual value rather than any worldly benefit.

לא כאותן דשכנציב דמ׳ מ״ק.
ואנשים פחותי הנפש האומרים
אליו חיה תחיה לא תמות דהוא
כמאן דמחו ליה מאה עובלי
בעובלי וגם שאמרו אפי׳ חרב
חדה מונחת וכו׳ אל ימנע עצמו
מן הרחמים מ״מ היכא דשכיחא
סכנתא שאני. ועוד כי הילודים
למות והפלוסוף אומר שכל הוה
נפסד. הגם שלבנו לא כן ידמה
ואין למדין מן הכללות כי החטא
דוקא הוא הממית ומכלה לאדם
הנברא בצלם ודמות הנה מצינו
ששלח הקב״ה להודיע לחזקיהו
כי מת אתה רק יודיעהו כי עת
לעשות לה׳ ושיפה שעה אחת
בתשובה בעה״ז מכל חיי העה״ב
ויפה כח בעלי תשובה שברגע
שאול יחתו בתשובתם ויקר בעיני
ה׳ המותה לחסידיו והרוצה שלא
יסריח את מתו יהפכנו בחייו עם
פניו למעלה. ברם אחר מיתתו
אמרו בפ״ק ע״א אמרו בי רב
הרוצה שלא יסריח מתו יהפכנו
על פניו ואין לך שיחה נאה יותר
מזו שאין הקב״ה מקפח שכרה
כדאמרו בב״ק: [i]

of thorns.[1] And although they said, "Even if a sharp sword rests on a person's neck, he should not hold himself back from mercy," nevertheless, when danger is common, it is different.

Moreover, those who are born are destined to die, and the philosopher says that all that exists will perish. Although our hearts do not imagine it thus, and one cannot learn from generalities because it is specifically sin that causes death and destruction to a person created in the image and likeness of God. We find that the Holy One, blessed be He, sent to inform Hezekiah, "You shall die," only to inform him that "it is time to act for the Lord,"[2] and that one hour of repentance in this world is better than all the life of the World to Come. Great is the power of penitents who in a moment break the depths of Sheol with their repentance. Precious in the eyes of the Lord is the death of His pious ones. One who wishes that his dead not decay should turn him while alive with his face upward. However, after death, they said in the first chapter, page 71, "In the house of Rav they said: One who wishes that his dead not decay should turn him onto his face."[3] There is no conversation more pleasant than this, for the Holy One, blessed be He, does not withhold its reward, as they said in Bava Kamma. 1570R 1575R 1580R 1585R 1590R

וישתדלו שיהיו י׳ בני ברית

They should endeavor to have ten Jews present

[1] This vivid Aramaic metaphor (כמאן דמחו ליה מאה עובלי בעובלי) describes the psychological harm caused by false reassurance, showing that insincerity toward the dying is considered spiritually violent.

[2] This phrase from Psalms 119:126 (עת לעשות לה׳) was often invoked to justify extraordinary measures when circumstances required it. Here it justifies being truthful with the dying to enable proper spiritual preparation.

[3] These seemingly practical instructions about positioning the body have both practical and mystical significance, connected to beliefs about preventing decomposition and facilitating the soul's departure.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The Zohar in Vayechi explains in mystical terms how one should treat the dying person and prepare their soul for departure. The author cites this as a key source for his guidance. | Cf. Berakhot — This Talmudic reference supports the author's recommendation that the dying person should accept divine judgment with love, citing the merit of one who acknowledges God even in suffering. | Cf. Rabbi Akiva's death narrative — The reference to Rabbi Akiva (abbreviated as ר״ע) points to the famous Talmudic account of his martyrdom, where he recited the Shema while being executed, demonstrating complete love of God even at death. | Cf. Tosafot on Menachot — The author cites this medieval commentary to establish the concept that the angel Michael serves as a heavenly priest offering the souls of the righteous as spiritual sacrifices. | Cf. Ecclesiastes — The author draws on Ecclesiastes' meditation on the inevitability of death, while adding the qualification that death comes specifically from sin, not merely as a natural process.

באהלו בשעת פטירתו ואמרו
רז״ל[i] שיסירו משם כל דבר
מטונף ומלבד כמה טעמים שיש
במספר הי׳ עוד הם לקראים
מחנה אלהים כדאמרי׳ בירו׳
דערובין[ii] כמה מחנה אלהים י׳
דשכינה שרויה ביניהם כדתנן
באבות[iii] וכן בברכות בי׳
שמתפללין והא דאמרי׳ בב״ק
פ׳ מרובה[iv] שאין השכינה שורה
בפחות מכ״ב אלף היינו לענין
הנבואה. והנה בהיות שם י׳
מישראל יהיה מחנה התחתון
לקראת מחנה עליון בי רוח
החיות העליונות באופנים אשר
לנשמות בארץ ויקרא שם המקום
ההוא מחנים.[v] ומאותם מחנות
תטול הנשמה העולה מלאכים
עמה ללותה ולהגין עליה מנץ
הטורף.[vi] אשרי המקדש עצמו
בעה״ז. ואמרו ברעיא מהימנא

in the tent at the time of death.[A] Our Sages of blessed memory instructed that all unclean things should be removed[1] from there. Beyond the several reasons associated with the number ten, they are also considered "God's camp," as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud tractate Eruvin: "How many constitute God's camp? Ten, for the Divine Presence dwells among them," as we learned in Pirkei Avot and similarly in Berakhot regarding ten who pray together. As for what is stated in Bava Kamma chapter "Merubah" that the Divine Presence does not rest on fewer than twenty-two thousand, that refers specifically to prophecy. Thus, when ten Israelites are present, the lower camp meets the upper camp,[B] for the spirit of the supernal living beings is in the wheels that correspond to souls on earth,[2] and that place is called "Mahanaim" (dual camps). From these camps, the ascending soul takes angels with it to accompany and protect it from the predatory hawk.[3] Fortunate is one who sanctifies himself in this world. And it states in

1595R 1600R 1605R 1610R

[A] Or: "One should strive to have a minyan (quorum of ten Jews) present in the room at the moment of passing." — This translation uses the specific Jewish term 'minyan' which is more precise in conveying the religious requirement of ten Jews for certain sacred functions, and uses 'room' instead of 'tent' to avoid confusion since this is not referring to a literal tent in most cases.

[B] Or: "the earthly assembly corresponds to the heavenly host" — This translation more clearly conveys the mystical concept that the human gathering below (ten Jews) creates a parallel to or connection with the angelic gathering above, making the metaphysical meaning more explicit for readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[1] This refers to ritual impurity but also to anything inappropriate that might disturb the sacred atmosphere needed for the soul's transition.

[2] This references the vision of Ezekiel's chariot (Ma'aseh Merkavah), a foundational text for Jewish mysticism. The "wheels" (ofanim) are a category of angels associated with divine movement between realms.

[3] In kabbalistic literature, souls ascending to heaven were thought to be vulnerable to negative spiritual forces, often symbolized as predatory birds. The presence of ten Jews and accompanying angels creates spiritual protection during this transition.

[i] Abbreviation for "ve-amru Rabboteinu Zichronam Livrachah" meaning "our Sages of blessed memory said." This is a common rabbinic formula used when citing teachings from the Talmudic sages.

[ii] Abbreviation for "bi-Yerushalmi de-Eruvin," referring to the Jerusalem Talmud tractate Eruvin.

[iii] "As we learned in Avot" refers to Pirkei Avot (Ethics of the Fathers) 3:6, which states that when ten people study Torah together, the Divine Presence dwells among them.

[iv] "And that which we say in Bava Kamma chapter Merubah" refers to a statement in the Babylonian Talmud.

[v] This is an allusion to Genesis 32:1-2, where Jacob encounters angels and names the place Mahanaim (literally "two camps"), symbolizing the meeting of earthly and heavenly realms. The author uses this as a metaphor for the meeting of human and divine presence at the deathbed.

[vi] "From the predatory hawk" refers to negative spiritual forces that might harm the soul during its ascent. This imagery comes from kabbalistic literature where birds of prey often symbolize harmful spiritual entities.

פ׳ כי תצא[i] על מה שאמרו רבנן
לפום צערא אגרא[ii] כי מפקנא
דנפש׳ מקודם דנפקת אית לה
צערא ברם לבתר דאפקת היא
ברחמי ורזא דמלה בבכי יבואו
ובתחנונים אובילם[iii] בתר דנא
ועת צרה היא ליעקב וממנה
יושע[iv] ויפקון ברחמי. וטוב יום
המות מיום הולדו וחוסה במותו
צדיק וכן אמרו והנה טוב מאד
זה מות עד כי יתגלה השפעת עין
החיים[v] ואז כימי העץ ימי עמי
ואכל וחי לעולם:[vi]

Ra'aya Mehemna, parashat Ki Tetze, regarding the sages' teaching "According to the suffering is the reward,"[A] that when the soul departs, before it leaves it experiences suffering, but after it has departed, it experiences mercy.[1] This is the secret meaning of "With weeping they shall come, and with supplications I will lead them" (Jeremiah 31:8). After this "it is a time of trouble for Jacob, but he shall be saved from it" (Jeremiah 30:7), and they shall depart with mercy. "Better is the day of death than the day of one's birth" (Ecclesiastes 7:1), and "The righteous finds shelter in his death" (Proverbs 14:32). And thus they said, "Behold, it was very good" (Genesis 1:31)—this refers to death, until the

[A] Or: "And in the Zoharic text Ra'aya Mehemna on the Torah portion Ki Tetze, it expounds on the rabbinic principle that "reward is proportionate to the struggle,"" — This translation clarifies that Ra'aya Mehemna is a Zoharic text (part of Kabbalah's primary work) and offers a more accessible rendering of the Aramaic phrase 'leFum tza'ara agra' that better conveys its meaning to modern readers.

[1] This presents a central teaching of Ma'avar Yabok: while the moment of death involves suffering, this is temporary and followed by divine mercy. This provided comfort to the dying and those attending them.

[i] Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd) is a section of the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism. The reference is to the portion corresponding to the Torah reading of Ki Tetze (Deuteronomy 21:10-25:19).

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means "According to the suffering is the reward" and comes from Pirkei Avot (Ethics of the Fathers) 5:23. It expresses the idea that spiritual reward is proportionate to the difficulty overcome.

[iii] This is a quotation from Jeremiah 31:8, "With weeping they shall come, and with supplications I will lead them." In context, it refers to the exile and redemption of Israel, but here it is applied to the soul's journey after death.

[iv] This is a quotation from Jeremiah 30:7, "It is a time of trouble for Jacob, but he shall be saved from it." Like the previous quote, it is reinterpreted here to refer to the soul's journey through difficulty to salvation after death.

[v] The Tree of Life is a central kabbalistic symbol representing divine creative energy flowing into creation. In eschatological contexts, it also refers to the immortality that will be restored in the messianic era.

[vi] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud Eruvin — This text is referenced to provide a rabbinic basis for having ten people present at death, suggesting that this creates a sacred space for the soul's transition. | Cf. Pirkei Avot — This reference reinforces the importance of a minyan (quorum of ten) as creating a sacred space where the Divine Presence dwells, making it appropriate for the soul's transition. | Cf. Tractate Berakhot — This reference connects prayer with the presence of ten people, suggesting that the minyan at death facilitates prayers that assist the soul's transition. | Cf. Bava Kamma — This reference is used to distinguish between the requirements for prophecy (22,000 people) versus the Divine Presence in ordinary circumstances (ten people), clarifying why ten suffices at a deathbed. | Cf. Zohar, Ra'aya Mehemna — This kabbalistic text is cited to reveal the mystical understanding of death as a transition from suffering to mercy, providing comfort about the ultimate fate of the departing soul. | Cf. Genesis 32:1-2 — This biblical allusion suggests that just as Jacob encountered angels at Mahanaim, the dying person encounters both earthly and heavenly beings at death, with ten people representing the earthly camp meeting the heavenly one. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:1 — This verse is cited to present death in a positive light, as the completion of life's purpose rather than merely its end, offering comfort to both the dying and those attending them.

flow of the Tree of Life is revealed,[1] and then "like the days of a tree shall be the days of My people" (Isaiah 65:22), and "he shall eat and live forever" (Genesis 3:22).

כתוב באורחות חיים[i] בני חוי זהיר לבקר את החולה כי המבקר מיקל חליו עליו והשתדל עמו לשוב לקונו[ii] והתפלל עליו וצא ואל תכביד עליו ישיבתך כי די לו מכובד חליו. כשתכנס לחולה תכנס אצלו שמח וטוב לב ודבר עמו בשמחה כי עיניו ולבו תלויים לנכנסים אצלו לבקרו:

It is written in Orchot Chaim: "My son, be diligent in visiting the sick, for the visitor eases the ill person's suffering.[2] Encourage them to return to their Creator, pray for them, and then leave—do not burden them with a lengthy stay, for they have enough to bear with the weight of their illness. When you enter to see a sick person, approach them with joy and a good heart, and speak to them cheerfully, for their eyes and heart depend upon those who come to visit them."[3]

בא יבא ברנה יום הישועה[iii] כי אז יבולע המות לנצח[iv] ומחה ה׳ אלהים דמעה מעל כל פנים[v] עם כל עמו ישראל גאולים ונכון יהיה הר בית ה׳ בראש ההרים[vi] בעזר המאיר לארץ ולדרים וישרה עלינו רוח הקודש ונאמר לפניו שירות הרבה וישקני מנשיקות שנשק

The day of salvation shall surely come with joy,[4] for then death will be swallowed up forever, and the Lord God will wipe away tears from all faces, together with all His people Israel who are redeemed. The mountain of the Lord's house shall be established at the top of the mountains, with the help of the One who illuminates the earth and its inhabitants. The holy spirit will rest upon us, and we will recite many songs before Him. He will kiss me with the kisses

[1] This refers to the messianic era or World to Come, when death will be overcome and immortality restored through access to the Tree of Life, which was withheld after Adam and Eve's expulsion from Eden.

[2] The Hebrew 'מיקל חליו עליו' literally means 'lightens his illness upon him,' reflecting the Jewish understanding that proper visitation can have a tangible effect on alleviating suffering.

[3] This beautiful expression captures the psychological and emotional impact of visitation—the sick person's hopes, spirits, and emotional wellbeing are significantly affected by how visitors approach them.

[4] The Hebrew uses a grammatical doubling ('בא יבא') for emphasis, which I've rendered as 'shall surely come.'

[i] Orchot Chaim (Paths of Life) is a halakhic work composed by Rabbi Aharon HaKohen of Lunel in the 14th century. It contains laws and ethical teachings organized around daily life and ritual observance.

[ii] This highlights that visiting the sick in Jewish tradition involves spiritual care alongside physical comfort—encouraging repentance and reconnection with God is considered an essential part of the visitation.

[iii] This opening combines Isaiah 35:10 ('they shall come with singing') with other biblical phrases to describe the day of redemption when death will be defeated.

[iv] This phrase is drawn from Isaiah 25:8: 'He will swallow up death forever,' referring to the ultimate elimination of death in the messianic era.

[v] A direct quote from Isaiah 25:8: 'The Lord God will wipe away tears from all faces,' describing divine comfort in the messianic age.

[vi] This comes from Isaiah 2:2 and Micah 4:1, describing the elevation of the Temple Mount in messianic times.

לבניו[i] וביום ההוא יהיה ה׳ אחד ביחוד עליון ושמו אחד ביחוד התחתון:[iii] [ii]

that He kissed His children,[A] and on that day, the Lord will be One in the supreme unification, and His name One in the lower unification.[1]

ועל טוב יזכר תחתון שם הקצין ונשא ומאד נעלה המשכיל והנבון כמה״ר מצליח מנחם בכמה״ר מתתיה פואה זצ״ל שמכבר היה אביו הנז׳ ריעי אשר כנפשי כי שנינו יחד צמודים יצקנו מים ע״י החסיד וקדוש האלוף כמה׳ הלל ממודינה זצוק״ל והיה לבו כלב הארי בכל מדע. וזכה כי נצר טוב מטע ה׳ להתפאר משרשיו פרה ורבה הנה הוא הקצין בנו הנז׳ אשר עשה לי סמוכות וקדש אותי במלוה להדפיס ספר הלז. הנה ברך לקחתי לאיש חיל רב פעלים הלז כי צדקתו הוא סמכתני וגם שהיא ברכת הדיוט קלה ולא בקול המולה לתת שבח וגדולה כי נודע בשערים טוב לבו ונדבתו בכל דבר

Let the name of the dignified, exalted, and highly elevated leader, the insightful and discerning Rabbi Matzliach Menachem son of Rabbi Mattathias Puah of blessed memory, be remembered for good. His aforementioned father was my beloved friend, dear as my own soul, for together we were bound as one, pouring water [studying] under the guidance of the pious and holy[B] master Rabbi Hillel of Modena, may the memory of the holy righteous one be a blessing. His heart was like a lion's heart in all knowledge. He merited a good offspring, a plant of the Lord for glory, who from his roots has flourished and multiplied—namely the aforementioned dignitary, his son, who provided me support and sanctified me with a loan to print this book. I hereby take a blessing for this man of valor with many accomplishments, for his righteousness has sustained me.[2] Though mine is but a simple blessing of an ordinary person and not like a resounding voice of-

[A] Or: "And He will kiss me with the kisses with which He kissed His children" — This alternate translation is more literal and preserves the relative clause structure of the Hebrew original. It's slightly less smooth in English but more precisely matches the Hebrew syntax.

[B] Or: "we poured water [a metaphor for serving/studying with] under the guidance of the pious and holy" — The metaphor of 'pouring water' in rabbinic contexts often refers to serving a master or studying under their guidance. This alternate makes the service relationship more explicit.

[1] These terms ('יחוד עליון' and 'יחוד התחתון') are technical kabbalistic concepts referring to the unification of divine attributes in the upper and lower spiritual worlds. In Kabbalistic thought, the messianic redemption will bring complete harmony between all levels of reality.

[2] The author employs wordplay here, as the Hebrew term for 'sustain' (סמכתני) relates to the earlier description of the patron providing 'support' (סמוכות).

[i] This adapts language from Song of Songs 1:2 ('Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth') but modifies it to speak of God kissing His children, referring to the intimate divine connection in the messianic age.

[ii] This adapts Zechariah 14:9 ('on that day the Lord will be one and His name one') but adds kabbalistic terminology about upper and lower unifications, referring to the complete harmony between different aspects of divinity in the messianic era.

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 25:8 — This verse from Isaiah is used as a foundational text for the Jewish conception of the messianic era, when death will be eliminated. The author invokes this prophecy to describe the ultimate hope that contextualizes the book's teachings about death—while death is currently a reality requiring proper ritual attention, it will eventually be overcome. | Cf. Zechariah 14:9 — The author alludes to this verse about divine unity in messianic times by adding kabbalistic terminology about 'upper' and 'lower' unifications. This transforms the biblical prophecy into a mystical meditation on how the messianic era will bring harmony between different aspects of the divine presence across all spiritual worlds. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:2 — The author alludes to this verse from Song of Songs, which is traditionally interpreted as expressing Israel's desire for intimate connection with God. By modifying it to refer to God kissing 'His children,' the text emphasizes the parent-child relationship between God and Israel that will be fully restored in messianic times.

שבקדושה. ואיהו יאי וגולתא
דדהבא ודכספא אשר חננו ה׳
ליה יאי ויאי. ומרגניתא דל״ת
בה טימי כל מה דאת משבח לה
את פגים לה. ויזכהו ה׳ לישא
בת ת״ח ואח״כ בת גדולי הדור.
מברכות פי אברך שמו הגדול
כי טוב לעולם חסדו. יהי רצון
שכל הנטיעות היוצאות ממנו
בחכמה ובענוה ויראת חטא
בעושר וכבוד והדר רצוי לשמים
ולבריות ולוקח מהם ברכה
לעדה הקדושה בזכות תומכי
התורה אשר צדקתם עומדת
לעד ככוכבי שמיא ומיני הקצין
אביהם יראו וישמחו וכי״סו לעד
יכון ברצונו הנאדרי וכרצון
אוהב שמו קרובו ומשרתו חיתא
דקטרי אבמ״י הצעיר ממשפחתי
ומבית אבי. ואני אהרן ברכיה
ממודינ״ה הקטן ממשפחתי
תפלתי לאל גואלי רצה נא אדני
קול תחנוני אורך ימים תודיעני
ושובע שמחות תשביעני הודיעני
דרך זו אלך דרך אמונה ועיני
ומעייני באמונתך יהיו הנה נא
פתחתי פי דברה לשוני בחכי
זה החלי בשם אלוה כל בריה
יגדל נא כח אדני לשמוע תפלתי
וימחה כעב פשעי וכענן חטאתי
ואל תתן את פי לחטוא את בשרי
היה עם פי בהגיוני ושמור דרכי
מחטוא בלשוני. אנא אלהי אנא
פתח לבי בתורתך פתוחי חותם
יחד לבבי ליראה את שמך נצח
נצחים עיני ולבי קרב אותם אחד
אל אחד והיו לאחדים בידך
שימה נא ערבני עמך זבד טוב
בחותם על זרועך הנאדרי. העיר

fering praise and greatness, his goodness of heart and generosity in all matters of holiness are well-known in the gates. He is worthy, and the golden and silver crown[1] that the Lord has graciously bestowed upon him is most becoming. As for the pearl without price, the more one praises it, the more one diminishes it.[A] May the Lord grant him to marry a daughter of Torah scholars and afterward a daughter of the greatest scholars of the generation. With the blessings of my mouth I bless His great name, for His kindness endures forever. May it be His will that all the offspring that come from him possess wisdom, humility, and fear of sin, with wealth, honor, and splendor, pleasing to Heaven and to people. May he receive from them blessing for the holy congregation, by the merit of the supporters of Torah whose righteousness stands forever like the stars of heaven. May his father's descendants see and rejoice, and may his wealth be established forever according to his glorious will and according to the desire of one who loves his name, his relative and servant who connects bonds, ABMI,[B] the youngest of my family and my father's house. 1675R 1680R 1685R 1690R 1695R

And I, Aaron Berechia of Modena, the least of my family, this is my prayer to God my Redeemer: Please, Lord, accept the voice of my supplication. Make me know the length of days and satisfy me with abundant joy. Show me the path I should walk, the way of faith, and may my eyes and my wellsprings be in Your faithfulness. Behold, I have opened my mouth, my tongue speaks in my palate. This beginning is in the name of the God of all creation. May the strength of the Lord be magnified to hear my prayer, may He wipe away like a cloud my transgressions and like mist my sins. Do not let my mouth sin against my flesh; be with my mouth in my meditation and guard my ways from sinning with my tongue. Please, my God, please open my heart to Your Torah with engraved seal. Unite my heart to fear Your 1700R 1705R 1710R

[A] Or: "And for a priceless pearl, whatever praise you give it only diminishes its value" — This Aramaic expression is somewhat difficult to translate elegantly. This alternate provides a slightly more direct rendering while preserving the meaning that excessive praise can actually diminish the value of something truly precious.

[B] Or: "his relative and servant, the thread that binds, ABMI" — The phrase 'חיתא דקטרי' is challenging. It may refer to someone who connects or binds things together, possibly in a metaphorical sense as a mediator or one who maintains relationships. This alternate offers a more poetic rendering.

[1] The Aramaic phrase 'גולתא דדהבא ודכספא' (crown of gold and silver) metaphorically refers to wealth and prosperity that God has bestowed upon the patron.

והקדש לפני תבנה בנין עדי עד
ובזרועי אקבץ אבנים לבצר
החומה ובתיקי אשא נפוצות
יהודה ויזכני ה׳ לראות יום יהיה
אור הלבנה כאור החמה ואור
החמה יהיה שבעתים ומציון תצא
תורה ודבר ה׳ מירושלים וזה
אלהים אלהינו עולם ועד הוא
ינהגנו על מות עולם שאין בו
מות הוא ינהגנו בשתי עולמות
בעה״ז בדכתיב כי ה׳ אלהיך
ברכך ובעה״ב כדכתיב ונחך
ה׳ תמיד והשביע בצחצחות
נפשך ועצמותיך יחליץ באורך
ימים ושנות חיים ושולם רב אשר
יוסיפו לנו עם כל ישראל אכי״ר
ויהי כבוד ה׳ לעולם ישמח ה׳
במעשיו: [i]

name for all eternity. My eyes and my heart—bring them close to each other that they may become one in Your hand. Place me as Your guarantor, a good gift, like a seal upon Your mighty arm.[1] May You build the city and the sanctuary before me[2] as an everlasting structure. With my arm I shall gather stones to fortify the wall, and in my bag I shall carry the dispersed of Judah. May the Lord grant me to see the day when the light of the moon shall be as the light of the sun, and the light of the sun shall be sevenfold, and Torah shall go forth from Zion and the word of the Lord from Jerusalem. And this God is our God forever and ever; He will guide us beyond death, to a world where there is no death. He will guide us in both worlds: in this world, as it is written, "For the Lord your God has blessed you," and in the World to Come, as it is written, "And the Lord will guide you continually and satisfy your soul in drought, and make your bones strong." With length of days and years of life and abundant peace, which shall be added to us together with all Israel. Amen, may it be His will. May the glory of the Lord endure forever; may the Lord rejoice in His works.

1715R 1720R 1725R 1730R

פרק ב׳

Chapter 2

מפתח ההקדמה מס׳ מעבר יבק

Introduction to the book Ma'avar Yabok

פתח פתחתי למעבר יבק
הלז[ii] למען ירוץ קורא

I have created an opening[3] to this Ma'avar Yabok so that one who reads it may run through it[4] and the

[1] This is an allusion to Song of Songs 8:6, 'Place me as a seal upon your heart, as a seal upon your arm,' which in Jewish mystical tradition symbolizes the intimate connection between God and the Jewish people.
[2] This refers to the rebuilding of Jerusalem and the Temple, a central messianic hope in Jewish tradition.
[3] The Hebrew "פתח פתחתי" uses a doubled verb form that creates emphasis and poetic rhythm that is difficult to capture in English. It literally means "I have opened an opening."
[4] The Hebrew uses the idiom "ירוץ קורא" (the reader will run) which suggests both speed and ease of navigation through the text.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author is using this imagery to request that God maintain a close spiritual bond with him, protecting him and marking him as belonging to the divine service. | Cf. Isaiah 30:26 — The author is expressing hope for messianic redemption, when spiritual illumination will be greatly magnified and the current limitations of our understanding will be removed. | Cf. Psalms 73:24 — The author is praying for divine guidance and physical/spiritual strengthening, connecting his individual request to biblical promises of divine sustenance for the righteous.
[ii] The title "Ma'avar Yabok" (Crossing of the Yabok) refers to Jacob's biblical crossing of the Yabok River (Genesis 32), which is used as a metaphor for the soul's transition from this world to the next—the central theme of this book on death and dying.

בו[iii] וימצא ההוגה בתוכו
את מבוקשו ולא יהיו עיניו
משוטטות אנה ואנה ע״כ[i] שיחן
ערכתי לפני כל הקרב לשמוע
את דבר ה׳ בלמודים אשר
בתוכו. ואלה הם ציוני תאיו
ואולמיו[ii] ואם מצער הם תחי
נפשי בהם.[iii]

one who studies it may find what they seek, without their eyes wandering here and there. Therefore, I have arranged my discourse[1] before all who approach to hear the word of the Lord in the teachings contained within. These are the markers[2] of its chambers and halls, and though they are few, may my soul live through them.[3]

תפלה לאל חיי יתן ויחזור
ויתן חוסן ישועות חכמה ודעת.
ישועת עולמים יש לנו בבית
מלכו של עולם[iv] על כן והנה
טוב מאד זה מוח שביום ההוא
הוא לידת הנשמות.[v] סדר הנהגת
צור חי העולמים עם האדם
בתנומות עלי משכב בחלומות.
פי׳ החלומות שוא ידברו. במה
נאמר דברי חלומות לא מעלין
ולא מורידין איך באים יסורים
על האדם בהדרגה ראשונה
מיחושים ואח״כ קדחת קלה
ואח״כ אשא דגרמי אח״כ חולאים
אחרים[vi] ומוכיח כל זה מפסוקי

A prayer to the living God who gives and will give again strength, salvation, wisdom, and knowledge.[4] We have eternal salvation in the house of the King of the Universe; therefore, "behold, it was very good"—this is the intellect that on that day becomes the birthplace of souls. The order of governance by the Eternal Rock of the Worlds with humanity is through slumbers upon the bed in dreams. The interpretation of dreams that speak falsehood. In what context do we say "dream matters neither elevate nor lower"? How sufferings come upon a person in gradual stages: first minor discomforts, then mild fever, then burning of the bones, then other illnesses[5]—and he proves all this from verses of Elihu. Whenever a person, due to his illness, cannot

[1] The Hebrew "שיחן" is a poetic term for discourse or conversation that has connotations of both formal teaching and intimate dialogue.
[2] The Hebrew "ציוני" literally means "signs" or "markers" and refers to the organizational elements that help navigate the text.
[3] This concluding phrase expresses the author's hope that his work, despite its modest scope, will have spiritual benefit for both himself and his readers. It reflects the common rabbinic belief that one's teachings perpetuate one's spiritual legacy.
[4] This opening prayer establishes the text's theological framework, viewing God as the source of both physical and spiritual sustenance, particularly relevant for a work focused on illness and death.
[5] The author presents a progressive model of illness as divine communication, each stage serving as a stronger warning if previous signals were ignored. This perspective frames illness not as random misfortune but as purposeful divine intervention.

[i] This alludes to Habakkuk 2:2, "Write the vision and make it plain upon tablets, that he who reads it may run." The author is suggesting that his organization of the material will allow readers to move quickly through the text and find what they need.
[ii] An abbreviation for "על כן" (therefore/for this reason).
[iii] The author uses architectural terminology (chambers and halls) as a metaphor for the structure and organization of his book, drawing on biblical language used to describe the Temple.
[iv] This phrase combines biblical allusions. "מצער" (few/small) appears in contexts of humility, while "תחי נפשי" (may my soul live) echoes Genesis 19:20 where Lot requests to flee to a small city. The author is expressing hope that even his modest contribution will have spiritual value.
[v] This phrase draws on the imagery of the Temple as God's dwelling place, suggesting that eternal salvation comes from connection to divine presence.
[vi] This is a kabbalistic concept connecting the brain/intellect (moach) with spiritual birth or renewal of souls.
[vii] The text presents a progressive model of illness as divine communication: first minor discomforts, then mild fever, then bone-burning fever, and finally other critical illnesses.

אליהוא. כל זמן שאדם מחמת
חליו אינו יכול להתפלל ידע כי
הנשמה מסתלקת ממנו ומצפה
איך יצא דינו ככתוב בזהר
פרשת ויחי דף רכ״ז.[i] ולדעתי
צלם זה המסתלק מהאדם תלתין
יומין קודם פטירתו יהיה החלק
הנכבד מנשמתו לפי מדרגתו
באשר דרשנו בתחלת דרוש זה:
יזהר האדם במעשיו דלא ליתרע
מזליה. וראיה מהזהר. אפי׳
בעת דכדוכה של נפש אם יש
עליו מלאך מליץ מצוא כופר:
טוביות היסורים וראיה מדברי
רז״ל בגמ׳ ובמדרשות ושהם
חסד לעולם. אשרי המחזק ידים
רפות בדבריו וברכים כושלות
בחולי יאמץ באמרי פיו: ראיה
מר׳ שמעון בו יוחאי בפרשת
בשלח והאזינו מה יעשה האדם
ההולך לבקר החולה דבעי
למשתדל על אסוותא דגופא:
ברם יעשה עקר למאסוואתא
דנשמתא ואשרי משכיל אל דל
ויש ממונים בהיכלות הקדושה
לשלם שכר למזכירים לחולה
שיפשפש במעשיו. למה נקרא
ביקור חולים. קצת הדברים
הראויים לזכור לחולה ועל
הכל ילמדהו דעת לחשוב כי
ביסורין מקיים כי עליך הורגנו
כל היום[ii] ושיהיה שברו על
ה׳ אלהיו. איך בחלישת הגוף
נחלש כח החצונים כי הבסיל

pray, he should know that his soul is departing from
him and awaiting the outcome of his judgment,
as written in the Zohar, Parshat Vayechi, page
227. In my opinion, this image that departs from a
person thirty days before his death is the honored 30R
portion of his soul according to his spiritual level,
as we explained at the beginning of this discourse.
A person should be careful in his actions not to
damage his fortune,[A] with evidence from the Zohar.
Even at the time of crushing of the soul,[B] if he has 35R
an advocating angel, a ransom will be found. The
benefits of suffering, with evidence from our Sages'
words in the Talmud and Midrashim, showing that
they are an act of kindness for the world. Blessed
is one who strengthens feeble hands with his words 40R
and encourages knees weakened by illness with his
speech. Evidence from Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai
in Parshat Beshalach and Ha'azinu about what a
person visiting the sick should do, as he must strive
for the healing of the body. However, he should 45R
focus primarily on healing the soul, and blessed is
one who considers the poor. There are appointed
beings in the holy chambers who reward those who
remind the sick person to examine his deeds. Why
is it called "visiting the sick" (bikur cholim)? Some 50R
things appropriate to mention to the sick person,
and above all, to teach him to understand that
through suffering he fulfills "For Your sake we are
killed all day long" and that his hope should be in
the Lord his God. How through the weakening of 55R
the body, the power of external forces is weakened,
for the fool Samael eats his flesh.[C] It is no joy
to the Angel of Death when he kills a person.
Through sufferings, the power of holy judgments is

[A] Or: "not to harm his spiritual destiny" — The concept of 'mazal' in kabbalistic contexts often refers to spiritual destiny or celestial connection rather than just fortune. This translation better captures the mystical dimension.

[B] Or: "when the soul reaches its lowest point" — While 'crushing' is literal, this alternative conveys the metaphorical meaning in more accessible English while preserving the notion of spiritual nadir.

[C] Or: "the foolish Angel of Death consumes his flesh" — The acronym ס״מ (Samael) refers to the Angel of Death in Jewish mystical tradition. The alternate translation provides clarity for readers unfamiliar with this reference.

[i] This refers to a passage in the Zohar (the central text of Jewish mysticism) that discusses how the soul begins to withdraw from a severely ill person who cannot pray.

[ii] This references Psalms 44:23, where suffering is portrayed as a form of sacrifice. The author suggests that patients should view their suffering as service to God.

ס״מ אוכל בשרו.[iii] לאו חידו
הוא למ״ה כד קטיל בר נש.
ביסורים מתמתקים כח הדינים
הקדושים וגוף הצדיק נקרב
קרבן לה׳. פי׳ קויי ה׳ יחליפו
כח למה התורה נקראת תושיה.
מוצא המזון של ת״ח ואיך חונים
מהקדושה הכמוסה בפת בגם
ויין משתיהם. כל צדיק יש לו
מדור בפני עצמו וא״צ לומר
שלא ינוח שם שבט הרשע על
גורל הצדיקים. דברי תשובה
של ש״מ ככתובים וכמסורים
למעלה דמי ע״כ טוב לערוך
שלחן לפני כל ירא וחרד לנפשו
עם פת ובשר ויין ובפרט לאותם
דלא תני תונא ולא הלכתא
וספרא וספרי כל עוד שמעשה
בני אדם בדבר מצוה לא יגרום
פירוד למטה מיחד או עושה
נחת רוח למעלה. השומע מפי
קטן שבישראל כשומע מפי משה
רבינו ע״ה ואפי׳ מפי הקב״ה
כביכו״ל. אין לגדול להתבייש
ללמוד מקטן. מהות קצת דרושי
הספר בקוצר ולמה נקרא מעבר
יבק. מורה מקום ממשל יפה
על המנוחה שבעולם הנשמות.
למה לחלק הכפר הלז לד׳
מאמרות ושמם. והרביעי נחלק
לג׳ חלקים להיותם דרושים
שונים. קצת מכללי כללים
דרושים אשר באו בג׳ מאמרים
הראשונים. ג׳ מערכות פסוקים
א׳ להרגיל האדם בהם בכל
יום ערב ובקר. הב׳ מיוחדים

sweetened,[1] and the body of the righteous is offered as a sacrifice to God. The interpretation of "Those who hope in the Lord will renew their strength." Why the Torah is called "wisdom." The source of nourishment for Torah scholars and how they benefit from the hidden holiness in bread, meat, and wine. Every righteous person has his own dwelling place, and it goes without saying that the rod of the wicked will not rest upon the lot of the righteous. The words of repentance of a deathly ill person are considered as if written and delivered above; therefore, it is good to set a table before every God-fearing person who trembles for his soul, with bread, meat, and wine,[1] especially for those who do not study Mishnah, laws, Sifra, or Sifrei, as long as human deeds in matters of commandments do not cause division below or create pleasure above. One who hears from the least in Israel is like one who hears from Moses our teacher,[2] peace be upon him, and even from the Holy One, blessed be He, as it were. A great person should not be ashamed to learn from a lesser one. The nature of some of the book's discourses briefly and why it is called "Crossing of the Yabok."[3] It indicates a beautiful metaphorical place for the rest in the world of souls. Why this book is divided into four discourses and their names. And the fourth is divided into three parts because they are different discourses. Some of the general principles and discourses that appear in the first three discourses. Three arrangements of verses: the first to accustom a person to recite them daily, evening and morning; the second specifically for the sick person in his discomfort and illness to entreat God with them for healing; the third for one who is greatly oppressed by the world. There is nothing superior to the arrangement of verses

60R 65R 70R 75R 80R 85R 90R 95R

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgments' (המתקת הדינים), where divine severity is transformed into mercy through proper spiritual processes. Suffering is thus viewed as spiritually productive.

[2] The author suggests providing physical nourishment alongside spiritual guidance, showing a holistic approach to caring for the ill and dying that addresses both body and soul.

[3] This statement reflects the author's view that divine wisdom can come through any person regardless of status, encouraging readers to be receptive to spiritual guidance from all sources, particularly relevant in end-of-life contexts.

[4] The book's title references Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River (Genesis 32), which preceded his transformative wrestling with an angel. This serves as a metaphor for the soul's transition from life to death.

[i] ס״מ (Samael) is a kabbalistic name for the Angel of Death. The text uses the metaphor of the Evil Inclination consuming one's flesh during illness.

לחולה במיחושו וחוליו יעתר בהם אל אלוה וירפאהו. הג׳ למי דתקיף ליה עלמא. אין למעלה מסדר הפסוקים בתפלה. ופי׳ העוסקים במקרא מדה ואינה מדה. רהוטו צדיקי בני חבורות ג״ח שבכל עיר ועיר למעבד רעותא דמרייכו ולפניכם יהיו למזכרת קצת מדברי חכמים אלה ופה הוצע קבוץ כונות ודברים שבקדושה אשר יאמרו לפני החולה עד כי תשוב שולמית נפשו אל ערי הרכב ויאתיו חשמנים לקראתה. יחזיקוהו בדבריהם באמונת תורתינו ובשאר י״ג עיקרי הדת וביחוד שמע ישראל וגו׳. חבורות צדיקים שיושבים בג״ע תחת עץ החיים בפסוק ששים המה מלכות וכו׳. למה אמרו תורה שאדם לומד בעה״ז הוא הבל לגבי תורה שבעה״ב. למה דרשות נקראים בריכות. רושם ושכר המפיק ד״ת ברבים. שכר הצפון לבני חבורות ג״ח ולכל א׳ מישראל המשתדלים להכניס נפש אחת מישראל באהבה וחבה ורצון לפני ה׳. יש ממונה לצד דרום בהיכל שלישי מהקדושה החוקק דיוקן הגומל חסד זה ודברי רשב״י בפרשת פקודי המפרשים דברי הצדיקים נוחי נפש בעה״ז יזכו כי יצאו לקראתם בעת מותם. שכר גדול מדברי חז״ל לג״ח. צווינו וזורזנו מדברי חז״ל בגמרא ובספר הזהר שכל העומד על החולה ורואה שנוטה למות ב״מ חייב להדיעו כי בגזרת עירין פתגמא ושהוא מחבקש בישיבה של מעלה ולבן עת הוא לו לעשות לה׳ כי יש קונה עולמו בשעה אחת לא כמנהג הפחותי נפש העוברים בזה על בל תונו איש את עמיתו ומצינו ברב פפא

in prayer. The explanation of those who engage in Scripture as "a measure that is not a measure." Run, O righteous members of charitable societies in every city, to do the will of your Master, and before you shall be a memorial of some of these words of the sages. Here is presented a collection of devotional intentions and holy matters to be recited before the sick person until his Shulamite soul returns to the cities of the chariots, and nobles will come to greet it. They should strengthen him with their words in the faith of our Torah and in the other thirteen principles of faith, especially the unity in "Hear, O Israel," etc. Groups of righteous ones who sit in the Garden of Eden beneath the Tree of Life, on the verse "There are sixty queens," etc. Why they said that the Torah a person learns in this world is vanity compared to the Torah in the World to Come. Why discourses are called "pools." The impression and reward for one who brings forth words of Torah in public. The reward reserved for members of charitable societies and for every individual in Israel who strives to bring a Jewish soul with love, affection, and will before the Lord. There is an appointee to the south in the third chamber of holiness who engraves the image of one who performs this kindness, and the words of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai in Parshat Pekudei. Those who interpret the words of the righteous who rest in peace in this world will merit that they will come out to greet them at the time of their death. Great reward from our Sages' words for acts of kindness. We are commanded and encouraged by our Sages' words in the Talmud and in the book of the Zohar that anyone who stands by a sick person and sees that he is inclined to die, God forbid, is obligated to inform hi[1]m that it is by the decree of the watchers and that he is being sought in the heavenly academy, and therefore it is time for him to act for the Lord, as one can acquire his world in a single hour. This is unlike the practice of those of base spirit who transgress in this matter the prohibition of "You shall not wrong one another." We find regarding Rav Papa, when he went to visit Rav Huna, the son of Rav Yehoshua, in Tractate Rosh Hashanah, first chapter, that he said, "Prepare provisions for him,"

100R 105R 110R 115R 120R 125R 130R 135R 140R

[1]The author advocates for truthfulness with the dying about their condition, contradicting the common practice of withholding such information. This ethical position is supported with a Talmudic precedent.

כשהלך לבקר רב הונא בריה
דרב יהושע במס׳ ר״ה פ״ק
דאמר תקינו ליה זוודתא והודיע
הדבר לחולה. והראייה שאח״כ
היה בוש ממנו אלא דאמר לו
רב הונא דהכי הוה וכו׳. טוב
שיהיו עשרה בני אדם שם בשעת
יציאת נשמה וטעם לזה. מפקנא
דנשמתא מקדמת דנפקת איתי
לה צערא. ברם לבתר דאפקת
היא ברחמי[i] וזהו בבכי יבואו
ובתחנונים אובילם.[ii] סדר
ביקור החולה מאורחות חיים.
בקשה ותחנה מהמחבר לאלהינו
מרחם יעזרהו על דבר כבוד שמו
עם כל ישראל חברים אכי״ר:[iii]

and informed the sick person of this. The proof is that afterward he was embarrassed before him, but Rav Huna said to him that this was indeed the case, etc. It is good for ten men to be present at the time of the soul's departure,[A] and the reason for this: The initial departure of the soul, as it begins to leave, is painful for it. However, after it has departed, it is with mercy,[1] and this is the meaning of "With weeping they will come, and with supplications I will lead them." The order of visiting the sick from Orchot Chaim. A request and supplication from the author to our merciful God that He may help him for the sake of the honor of His name, with all Israel as companions, Amen, so may it be His will.

[A] Or: "It is good for a minyan (quorum of ten Jews) to be present at the time of the soul's departure" — Including the term 'minyan' adds cultural context about the significance of having ten Jewish men present, which is an important concept in Jewish religious practice.

[1] This consoling teaching from Jewish mysticism suggests that while the transition of death is initially difficult, the soul experiences divine mercy after complete separation from the body.

[i] This Aramaic passage explains that while the soul experiences pain during its initial departure, after it fully leaves the body it experiences divine mercy.

[ii] This quotes Jeremiah 31:8, applied here to souls arriving in the afterlife with weeping but then being led with compassion.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parshat Vayechi — The author cites this Zohar passage to establish a kabbalistic framework for understanding the soul's gradual departure during serious illness. | Cf. Job 33 — The author uses Elihu's speech in Job as a biblical source for the concept that illness progresses in stages, each serving as a divine warning. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Beshalach — The author uses this Zoharic teaching to establish that while physical healing is important, spiritual healing should be the primary focus when visiting the sick. | Cf. Zohar, Ra'aya Mehemna — The author cites this mystical teaching to comfort readers with the knowledge that while the soul's departure is painful, it experiences divine mercy afterward. | Cf. Psalms 44:23 — This biblical verse is presented as a meditation for the sick person to view their suffering as a form of sacrifice and service to God. | Cf. Song of Songs 6:13 — The author uses this poetic biblical image to represent the soul's return to heavenly realms after death, providing a comforting metaphor for the transition. | Cf. Rosh Hashanah 22a — This Talmudic story is cited to prove that one should honestly inform the dying of their condition, rather than hide the truth from them. | Cf. Jeremiah 31:8 — This verse is applied to the soul's journey after death, suggesting that while departure is painful, God leads souls with mercy and compassion.

Part II

Discourses on sickness and death

Discourse 3

שפתי צדק / Lips of Righteousness

פרק א׳ — Chapter 1

מאמר א׳ מספר מעב״ר יב״ק[i] — The First Discourse from the Book Ma'avar Yabok

יהא רעוא.[ii] דאימא מלתא.[iii] דתתקבל ברעוא.[iv] קדם מלכא רמא.[v] וקדם צדקיא:[vi][vii] — May it be Your will[1] that I may speak words that will be received favorably before the exalted King[2] and before the righteous ones.[3]

אל ה׳ ויאר לנו וקדשנו במצותיו וצונו בהם לטוב לנו כל הימים ובהם יש בכחם יתר שאת ויתר עז בקצתם כי הקרן קיימת להם — To the Lord who illuminates us, sanctifies us with His commandments, and instructs us through them for our benefit all our days. These commandments possess greater strength and power, for their principal 5R

[1] The original doesn't specifically say "Your" but this is implied in the Aramaic phrase, which is a standard opening formula in Jewish prayer addressing God.
[2] This is a reference to God, using royal imagery that is common in Jewish liturgy.
[3] This may refer to righteous people in general, deceased righteous sages whose merit the author invokes, or the rabbinic authorities whose teachings he is drawing upon in this work.

[i] The title literally means "First Discourse from the Book Ma'avar Yabok". The word מאמר (ma'amar) refers to a discourse or treatise, while מעב״ר יב״ק (Ma'avar Yabok) refers to the "Crossing of the Yabok", a metaphorical reference to the biblical Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River before his transformative encounter with an angel. In this context, it symbolizes the soul's transition from life to death. The acronym יב״ק (YBK) equals 112 in gematria (Hebrew numerology), which the author will later connect to specific verses that aid the soul's transition.
[ii] This is an Aramaic phrase meaning "May it be [God's] will." It's a common opening formula in Jewish liturgical texts, particularly in Kabbalistic works.
[iii] Aramaic for "that I may speak words" or "that I may say something."
[iv] Aramaic phrase meaning "that will be received with favor/willingly."
[v] Aramaic for "before the exalted King," a reference to God.
[vi] Aramaic for "and before the righteous ones," which could refer to righteous people generally or specifically to the righteous sages whose teachings the author draws upon.
[vii] Cf. Zohar — This opening prayer resembles the introductory formula used in many sections of the Zohar, where discourses often begin with an Aramaic invocation seeking divine favor for the teachings about to be presented.

לעולם הבא ופירותיהם אוכל
האדם בעולם הנשמות הנקרא
עולם הזה. ופי׳ קרן ופירות
הוא[i] כי הקרן יהיה השפע שנשפע
על המלכות בסוד אור חוזר
ואור ישר[ii] בעת עשיית המצוה
ההיא כאשר יתבאר לקמן. ואחר
כך אותו האור נעשה פירות שהוא
כזרע הארץ שגדל ועושה פירות
ונזרע וחוזר ועושה פירות וכן
אותו האור הקדוש נזרע בארץ
העליונה[iii] ושם מגדל צמחים
ופירות: ובכלל המצות אלו יש
גמילות חסדים[iv] ירצה השפעת
החסד ממקומו וגם החסד שבמדת
הגבורה ולכן הם חסדים בלשון
רבים. ובהיות האדם עושה חסד
עם הבריות משפיע מצד החסד
ואם עושה בהם בכחו וגבורתו
ישפיעם מחסד שבגבורה[v] וזהו
גמילות חסדים ומצוה זו היא
עם החיים ועם המתים ובגופו
של אדם וגם בממונו. והיא
שקולה כזכות אבות. ואמרינן
בויקרא רבה פרשה ל״ו על
פסוק כי ההרים ימושו והגבעות

reward remains for the World to Come, while their
fruits are enjoyed by humans in the world of souls 10R
called This World.[1] The meaning of 'principal' and
'fruits' is that the principal is the divine flow that
descends upon Malkhut (Divine Presence) through
the mystery of reflected light and direct light at the
time of performing that commandment, as will be ex- 15R
plained later. Afterward, that light produces fruits,
like seeds of the earth that grow, yield fruits, are
sown again, and continue to yield fruits. Similarly,
that holy light is sown in the supernal earth,[2] where
it grows plants and fruits. 20R

Among these commandments is gemilut
chasadim (acts of loving-kindness), meaning
the channeling of kindness from its source,
including the kindness within the attribute of
Gevurah[3] (Strength). Thus, they are called 25R
'chasadim' in plural form. When a person performs
kindness toward others, they channel influence from
the side of Chesed (Kindness), and if they perform
these acts with their strength and might, they
channel from the kindness within Gevurah—this 30R
is gemilut chasadim. This commandment applies
to both the living and the dead, and involves both
one's body and wealth. It is equivalent to the merit
of the Patriarchs.[4] We say in Vayikra Rabbah,

[1]The author makes the somewhat counterintuitive statement that our physical world is actually "the world of souls," emphasizing that what appears material is in fact deeply spiritual from a mystical perspective.

[2]The text employs agricultural metaphors to describe spiritual processes, comparing divine light to seeds that produce ongoing spiritual harvests. This agricultural imagery is common in kabbalistic texts to explain how human actions generate cosmic effects.

[3]This reflects the kabbalistic concept of interinclusion (הכללות), where each divine attribute contains elements of the others. Though Gevurah primarily represents judgment and restriction, it contains an aspect of kindness that can be activated through human actions.

[4]This powerful statement elevates acts of kindness to the highest possible status, suggesting that

[i]This passage uses the rabbinic concept of 'principal and fruits' (קרן ופירות) to explain the metaphysical rewards of performing mitzvot. The 'principal' (קרן) represents the eternal reward preserved for the World to Come, while the 'fruits' (פירות) are benefits enjoyed in this world.

[ii]The kabbalistic terms 'or chozer' (reflected light) and 'or yashar' (direct light) describe the reciprocal flow of divine energy. Direct light descends from God to creation, while reflected light returns upward from human actions back to the divine realm.

[iii]The 'supernal earth' (ארץ העליונה) refers to the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom/Divine Presence), often symbolized as earth or soil in kabbalistic literature. The metaphor of sowing light as seeds indicates how human actions generate ongoing spiritual effects.

[iv]Gemilut chasadim (acts of loving-kindness) is considered one of the pillars of Jewish ethics, encompassing charity, visiting the sick, burying the dead, and other selfless actions. The text explains its kabbalistic dimension as channeling divine attributes.

[v]The text describes a kabbalistic concept where Chesed (Loving-kindness) exists within Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), illustrating how these seemingly opposite divine attributes contain elements of each other. This reflects the sophisticated understanding of the interpenetration of divine attributes in Jewish mysticism.

תמוטינה אם ראית זכות אבות שמטה וזכות אמהות שנתמוטטה לך והטפל בחסדים. ועיין בירושלמי דסוטה פ״ק גודל מצות גמילות חסדים וכן בגמרין שם ובמציעא ובשבת פרק מפנין. וביקור חולים גם כן היא מצוה שיש לה קרן ופירות[i] ונבאר סודה לקמן. ואמרו פרק אין בין המודר ובירושלמי דפאה, כי ביקור חולים מצוה על הכל ובפ׳ הנזכר נתבארו שעות הבקור. ועוד אמרו ז״ל בסוטה הקב״ה מבקר חולים וקובר מתים. ובפ״ק דשבת כתוב שכל המבקר את החולה צריך לבקש עליו רחמים[ii] ויהא בכאב לב והביקור בלי בקשת רחמים אינו מקיים המצוה. ורבנן קשישי דמתניתין ודברייתא בפיהם המתיקו מלין כי צריך לכלול החולה בתוך חולי עמו ישראל.[iii] וגם שאין יסורין בלא חטא אליבא דמאן מכל מקום גזר דין דרבים נקרע מה שאין כן גזר דין דיחיד מלבד כי יפה צעקה לאדם בין קודם גזר דין[iv] וכו׳:

chapter 36, regarding the verse “For the mountains may depart and the hills be removed”—if you see that the merit of the Patriarchs is declining[1] and the merit of the Matriarchs is faltering, go and engage in acts of kindness. See also the Jerusalem Talmud, Sotah, first chapter, regarding the greatness of the commandment of gemilut chasadim, as well as in our Talmud there, in Bava Metzia, and in Shabbat, chapter “Mefanin.” 35R 40R

Visiting the sick (bikur cholim) is also a commandment that has both principal and fruits, and we will explain its secret later. It is stated in the chapter “Ein Bein HaMudar” and in the Jerusalem Talmud of Pe’ah that visiting the sick is an obligation upon everyone,[2] and in the aforementioned chapter, the proper times for visitation are explained. Our Sages further stated in Sotah that the Holy One, blessed be He, visits the sick[3] and buries the dead. In the first chapter of Shabbat, it is written that whoever visits the sick must pray for mercy on their behalf with a pained heart, and visitation without praying for mercy does not fulfill the commandment.[4] The elder rabbis of the Mishnah and Baraita sweetened their words by explaining that one should include the sick person among all the sick of Israel. And even though according to some opinions there is no suffering without sin, nevertheless, a decree against 45R 50R 55R 60R

ordinary people can achieve spiritual merit comparable to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob through compassionate actions.

[1] This reflects the rabbinic concept that the protective merit of the ancestors might diminish over time, requiring each generation to establish its own spiritual achievements through acts of kindness.

[2] Unlike some commandments that apply only to certain individuals or in specific circumstances, bikur cholim (visiting the sick) is presented as a universal obligation, highlighting its fundamental importance in Jewish ethics.

[3] This anthropomorphic description of God performing human mitzvot serves as the ultimate model for human behavior, suggesting that when humans visit the sick, they are imitating divine actions.

[4] This emphasizes that the mitzvah requires both physical presence and spiritual intervention through prayer, establishing that proper bikur cholim has both material and metaphysical dimensions.

[i] The Mishnah in Peah 1:1 lists deeds whose ‘fruits’ (partial reward) one enjoys in this world while the ‘principal’ (full reward) remains for the World to Come. These include honoring parents, acts of kindness, and making peace between people. The text here adds visiting the sick to this category.

[ii] This reflects the Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 12b) that prayer is an essential component of visiting the sick. Without praying for the sick person’s recovery, the visit does not fulfill the mitzvah completely.

[iii] This refers to the rabbinic practice of praying for an individual within the context of all who are suffering from similar conditions. This has both theological significance (connecting the individual to the community) and practical benefit (since prayers for the community are considered more powerful).

[iv] This is a reference to the Talmudic teaching (Rosh Hashanah 18a) that crying out in prayer is effective even before a divine decree is sealed, and in some cases, even after.

ביום שבת דנהירו דעתיקא
אתגליא[i] והנהגת הרחמים רבים
מתפשטן בעולם מכח ז׳ מדרגות
הכסא שהוא עולם הבריאה
הנכלל בשם אכתריאל יה
ה׳ צבאות[ii] המתלבש בתוכם
האצילות הקדוש בשבעה היכלות
כנתבאר שמם בתקונים הנרמזים
בז׳ אותיות אהי״ה יה״ו ולהם ז׳
שמות הו״יה אלי״הוד נקוד חירק
סגול חירק אלהי״ם הוי״ה הוי״ה
אדנ״י כנתבאר בפקודין מאלה
הדברים פקודא כ״ד ביום הקדוש
ההוא כ״ש שצריך להתפלל על
החולה בלשון רבים משום דהוי
כצרכי רבים שמותר לשאול
אותם בשבת. ברם אסור לזעוק
עליו בשבת כמו שאמרו שבת היא
מלזעוק[iii] כי זעקה הוא גדולה.
מעשר לשונות של תפלה. והיא
היות האדם מתפלל עד שקצרה
יד לשונו שיצעק מכאב לב כי
היא במקום אסיפת המחשבה
הנרמז בכ״ע.[iv] ותכלית התפלה
היא שיעלה הצעקה מהלב.
ולזה אמרו שקורעת גזר דינו
של אדם כל ימיו. עוד אמרו
גדולה זעקה שמושלת על מדת

many can be torn up,[1] unlike a decree against an individual—aside from the fact that crying out is beneficial for a person even before a decree is issued, etc. 65R

On the Sabbath day, when the light of the Ancient One is revealed and abundant mercy spreads throughout the world through the power of the seven levels of the Throne,[2] which is the World of Creation (Beriah) encompassed by the 70R name Achtariel Yah YHVH Tzeva'ot, within which the holy emanation (Atzilut) clothes itself in seven palaces, as their names are explained in the Tikkunim (mystical works), alluded to in the seven letters AHYH YHV, and they have seven 75R names HVYH, ALYHVD with vowel points chirik-segol-chirik, ALHYM, HVYH, HVYH, ADNY, as explained in the commandments of Devarim, commandment 24—on that holy day, it is all the more necessary to pray for the sick in plural form 80R because it is considered a communal need,[3] which one is permitted to request on Shabbat. However, it is forbidden to cry out for the sick on Shabbat, as they said, "Shabbat prohibits crying out," for crying out is greater than the ten expressions of 85R prayer.[4] It refers to when a person prays until their tongue falls short and they cry out from heart pain, for this happens at the gathering place of thought, alluded to by "Crown of All" (Keter). The ultimate

[1] This reflects the rabbinic concept that collective prayer has greater spiritual power than individual prayer, explaining why including the individual in the community's suffering increases the efficacy of prayers for healing.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic understanding of the divine throne mentioned in Ezekiel's vision, with its seven levels corresponding to lower divine emanations that transmit divine influence to creation.

[3] This provides a halakhic (legal) justification for praying for the sick on Shabbat, as normally personal requests are limited on Shabbat, but communal needs may be addressed.

[4] Rabbinic tradition identifies ten terms for prayer in scripture (including 'cry,' 'plea,' 'supplication,' etc.). The text elevates emotional crying-out above all other forms of prayer for its spiritual potency.

[i] This Aramaic phrase translates as 'On Sabbath when the light of the Ancient One is revealed.' In Kabbalah, Shabbat is considered a time when higher divine attributes (particularly those associated with mercy) are more accessible than during weekdays.

[ii] Achtariel Yah YHVH Tzeva'ot is a divine name appearing in the Talmud (Berakhot 7a), associated with God as seen in a vision by Rabbi Ishmael in the Holy of Holies. The name combines 'keter' (crown) with 'El' (God) and other divine names.

[iii] This is from the formula recited on Shabbat for the sick: 'Shabbat prohibits crying out, but healing will soon come.' The text explains why intense emotional prayer (ze'akah/crying out) is inappropriate on Shabbat, when divine mercy is already more accessible.

[iv] The Hebrew abbreviation כ״ע stands for 'Keter Elyon' (Supreme Crown), the highest of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah, representing God's infinite will and the source of all divine emanation.

הדין של מעלה. עוד גדולה זעקה שמושלת בעולם הזה ובעולם הבא. עוד בשבילה נוחל העולם הזה והעולם הבא כי היא מבטלת אפילו מדת הדין הקשה. ודיני הבינה נמתקים על ידה ומחזרת האם על הבנים.[i] והרבה סגולות יש לה להיות מגעת כח התעוררותה לכ״ע. ולכן אין לזעוק בשבת מכאב לב על החולה. אך בחול חובה להצטער בצער החולה ולהתפלל עליו עד כי יגיע לידי הצעקה. ובזה יזכה לחזות בנועם ה׳ שהיא בינה ולבקר בהיכלו שהיא מלכות.[ii] הנה שברו אתו בעולם הזה ובעולם הבא סוד בינה ומלכות. וכתוב במדרש רבה שאף על פי שאינו בן גילו של חולה המבקר אותו מכל מקום מרויח לו ובפרק אין בין המודר אמר ר״ל רמז לבקור חולים מן התורה מנין דכתיב אם כמות כל האדם ימתון אלה ופקודת כל האדם יפקד עליהם.[iii] ושמעתי כי מסמיכים נטילת ששים מחליו[iv] למי שהוא בן גילו לפסוק ויתחזק ישראל וישב על

90R purpose of prayer is that the cry should rise from the heart. Therefore, they said that it tears up a person's decree all their days.[1] They also said: Great is crying out, for it rules over the attribute of Judgment above. Furthermore, great is crying out, 95R for it rules in this world and in the World to Come. Additionally, through it, one inherits this world and the World to Come, for it nullifies even the severe attribute of Judgment.[2] The judgments of Binah (Understanding) are sweetened through it, and it 100R causes the Mother to return to the children.[3] It has many special qualities, as the power of its awakening reaches the Crown of All. Therefore, one should not cry out from heart pain for the sick on Shabbat. However, on weekdays, it is an obligation to feel the 105R pain of the sick person and pray for them until one reaches the point of crying out. Through this, one will merit to behold the pleasantness of the Lord, which is Binah, and to visit His palace, which is Malkhut—behold, his reward is with him in this 110R world and in the World to Come, the secret of Binah and Malkhut.

It is written in Midrash Rabbah that even if one is not an age-mate of the sick person[4] who visits them, nevertheless, it benefits them. In the chapter "Ein Bein HaMudar," Reish Lakish said: From 115R where in the Torah do we find a hint to visiting the sick? From the verse "If these men die the common

[1] This emphasizes the extraordinary power attributed to heartfelt, emotional prayer to overturn even divine judgments that have been issued against a person.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, crying out in prayer has the power to transform harsh divine judgment (din) into mercy (rachamim), a process known as 'sweetening the judgments' (המתקת הדינים).

[3] This kabbalistic metaphor describes how the divine attribute of Binah (Understanding, the 'Mother') influences the lower sefirot (the 'children'), creating a flow of mercy and blessing in response to heartfelt prayer.

[4] The text addresses the folk belief that those of similar age to the patient have special healing influence, clarifying that while age-mates may have greater impact, anyone's visitation provides benefit.

[i] This kabbalistic expression refers to the divine attribute of Binah (Understanding, the 'Mother') turning toward and influencing the lower sefirot (the 'children'). It signifies a flow of divine mercy from higher to lower spiritual realms.

[ii] This interprets Psalm 27:4 ('to behold the pleasantness of the Lord and to visit His temple') as referring to experiencing the divine attributes of Binah (Understanding) and Malkhut (Kingdom), representing connection to higher spiritual realms.

[iii] This verse (Numbers 16:29) from Korah's rebellion is interpreted creatively in the Talmud (Nedarim 39b-40a) as a reference to visiting the sick. The word 'פקודת' (visitation/appointment) is understood as referring to others visiting them in their illness.

[iv] The tradition that visitors take away 1/60th of a sick person's illness appears in various rabbinic sources. The text offers a numerical interpretation based on the gematria (numerical value) of the Hebrew word for 'bed' (המטה = 59) to explain why the precise amount is 59/60 rather than exactly 1/60.

המטה. המט״ה בגימטריא נ״ט
כי בבא יוסף שהיה ודאי בן
גילו של אביו שזיו אקונין שלו
דומה לו[i] ועוד כל מה שאירע
ליעקב אירע ליוסף מלבד כי
מרכבתו במרכבת המשנה אשר
לו מדי בואו לבקר את אביו
אז התחזק ישראל מחליו וישב
על נ״ט חלקים ממנו בגימטריא
המ״טה וזה יותר צודק ממה
שאמרו ששים לאו דוקא. אלא
מרגלא הכי בפומא דרבנן[ii] שתין
תכלי מטו. שתין רהוטי רהוט
וכדומה:[iii]

death of all men, or if they be visited according to the visitation of all men." I have heard that they connect the taking of sixty parts of the illness by one who is the sick person's age-mate to the verse "And Israel strengthened himself and sat upon the bed." The word "bed" (HaMiTaH) in gematria equals 59, for when Joseph came—who was certainly his father's age-mate, as his facial features resembled his,[1] and moreover, everything that happened to Jacob happened to Joseph[2]—besides that, his chariot was the chariot of the viceroy which he had, whenever he came to visit his father, then Israel strengthened himself from his illness and sat up, relieved of 59 parts of it, according to the gematria of "HaMiTaH" (the bed).[3] This is more precise than saying that "sixty" is not exact, but rather it is common in the language of the rabbis to say "sixty vessels arrived" or "sixty runners ran" and the like.

פרק ב׳

Chapter 2

סדר בקשת רחמים בשהולך

The procedure for requesting mercy when visiting

[1]The midrashic tradition that Joseph physically resembled Jacob serves to strengthen the mystical connection between them that enabled Joseph's visit to have particular healing power.

[2]This reflects the rabbinic principle that Joseph's life paralleled his father's in many ways, establishing a spiritual resonance between them that enhanced Joseph's ability to heal Jacob through his presence.

[3]The author uses gematria (Hebrew numerology) to explain the precise amount of healing (59/60ths) that occurs when an age-mate visits the sick, connecting the value of 'the bed' (המטה = 59) to the traditional teaching about healing.

[i]The phrase 'ziv ikonin' (facial features or countenance) refers to the midrashic tradition that Joseph physically resembled his father Jacob. The Greek-derived term 'ikonin' (from 'icon' or 'image') is used in rabbinic literature to describe facial appearance.

[ii]This Aramaic phrase means 'it is common in the mouths of the rabbis' or 'it is a common saying among the sages.' The author explains that the number sixty is used as a conventional round number in many rabbinic expressions.

[iii]Cf. Mishnah Peah 1:1 — The author draws on this foundational Mishnah to categorize visiting the sick among the highest religious obligations that generate both immediate and eternal spiritual rewards. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 12b — The author incorporates this Talmudic teaching to establish that prayer is an essential component of properly visiting the sick, without which the mitzvah is not fulfilled. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Nedarim 39b-40a — The author cites this creative Talmudic interpretation to demonstrate that visiting the sick, while not explicitly commanded in the Torah, has implicit biblical support. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah 36:2 — The author uses this midrash to establish the supreme importance of gemilut chasadim (acts of kindness) as capable of sustaining the world even when the merit of the ancestors is insufficient. | Cf. Zohar, Pekudei — The author draws on Zoharic cosmology to explain how divine mercy flows through the spiritual worlds on Shabbat, making it a particularly appropriate time for healing. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Rosh Hashanah 18a — The author incorporates this teaching to emphasize the extraordinary power of emotional prayer to overturn divine judgments, even those that appear to be finalized. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 7a — The author references this Talmudic account to connect the divine name mentioned with the spiritual forces active on Shabbat that facilitate healing. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author draws on these kabbalistic teachings to explain the precise spiritual mechanics of how divine names channel healing energy during prayer.

לבקר את החולה. יראה שטוב לומר עליו פסוק לא תאונה אליך רעה ונגע לא יקרב באהלך.[i] כי רעה היא לילית[ii] שלא תתאנה אליו וכן נגע שהוא מראש ס״מ[iii] לא יקרב באהלך. ובזהר פ׳ שלח דף ס״ה קרא אותה רעה חולה ומהם מתהוה כל מין נגע ומחלה ותוצ״אות המיתה. ויוסיף כי מלאכיו יצוה לך דאינון מלאכין דקב״ה. יצוה לך ממש ייחדם עמך לשמרך ע״י אינון מלאכין. וכשהם עם האדם שכינה אשתכחת בהדיא לשמרך בכל דרכיך שהדרכים הם ממלכות לת״ת ומהת״ת למלכות ע״י היסוד הנקרא כ״ל.[iv] ויכוין עוד בכחות המושפעות מהמלך העליון לרפואת כל בשר המופקדים בהיכלות עליונות וגם יעלה במחשבתו באמרו כי מלאכיו יצוה לך צנורי אורות הממונים על שמירת יציאת הנשמה לבל תצטער ביציאתה אם ח״ו נגזר עליו מיתה בר מינן. וכתיב בסבא דף צ״ח ע״ב כי הקב״ה מהלך על כנפי רוח למיהב אסוותא לעלמא. ודא איהו רפא״ל המושפע ממלכות המקבלת מת״ת ששם ארוכה ומרפא בכח כ״ע:[v] וזהו רפאנו

the sick.[1] It seems appropriate to recite over the patient the verse: "No evil shall befall you, nor shall any plague come near your dwelling" (Psalm 91:10). For "evil" refers to Lilith,[2] that she should not befall him, and likewise "plague," which originates from the head of Samael, should not approach his tent. In the Zohar, Parshat Shelach page 65, it calls her "evil sickness," and from them arise all kinds of afflictions, diseases, and the outcomes of death. One should add: "For He shall give His angels charge over you" (Psalm 91:11)—these are the angels of the Holy One, blessed be He. "He shall give His angels charge over you" literally means that He assigns them to you to guard you through these angels. And when they are with a person, the Divine Presence is found explicitly with him "to keep you in all your ways" (Psalm 91:11)—where "ways" symbolize the paths from Malkhut to Tiferet and from Tiferet to Malkhut through the foundation called "Kol" (All).[3]

One should also focus on the powers that flow from the Supernal King for the healing of all flesh, which are appointed in the upper chambers. Additionally, when saying "For He shall give His angels charge over you," one should contemplate the channels of light appointed to guard the soul's departure so it will not suffer upon leaving, if, God forbid, death has been decreed upon the person (may we be spared).[4] It is written in Saba (Zohar) page 98b that the Holy One, blessed be He, walks upon the wings of the wind to bring healing to the world. This is Raphael, who receives influence from Malkhut, which

[1]This section outlines a specific kabbalistic ritual to be performed when visiting ill people, combining biblical verses with mystical meditations to promote healing.

[2]In Jewish mysticism, illness was often attributed to demonic forces, with Lilith (Adam's legendary first wife who became a demoness) specifically associated with disease and death.

[3]This describes the kabbalistic structure of divine emanations (sefirot), where Yesod (Foundation) serves as the channel connecting Tiferet (masculine aspect) with Malkhut (feminine aspect), facilitating the flow of divine energy.

[4]The Hebrew phrase 'bar minan' (may we be spared) is a traditional apotropaic formula used when mentioning death or misfortune, intended to ward off the possibility of such events affecting the speaker or listeners.

[i]This is Psalm 91:10, which the author interprets kabbalistically as protection against demonic forces.

[ii]The author identifies 'evil' (ra'ah) with Lilith, the female demonic figure in Jewish mysticism associated with disease and infant mortality.

[iii]The author identifies 'plague' (nega) as originating from Samael (abbreviated as ס״מ), the angelic figure associated with death and the satan in Jewish mysticism.

[iv]The foundation (Yesod) sefirah is called 'kol' (all) in kabbalistic terminology because it channels the combined influences of all the sefirot above it.

[v]This describes the kabbalistic flow of healing energy: from Keter Elyon (Supreme Crown) through

ה׳ שמא דאריך אנפין ושם עקר
הכונה ונמשכת הרפואה דרך
ג׳ ראשונות לחסד. והכתר
אינו משפיע לספירות אלא
בבחינת החסד. ונרפא למטה
בת״ת ומלכות. ונו״ן וא״ו הם
סוד נשמות ישראל האחוזים
בת״ת סוד וא״ו ובמלכות סוד
נו״ן הצריכים לרפואה והם
נקראים חולי אהבה הצריכים
אל היחוד:[i] ואם החולה הוא
בעל תורה יאמר עליו חברו
המבקרו יהא רעוא דתהא מבורך
מפומא דקב״ה ושכינתי׳[ii] בכל
מדה ומדה דיליה ובעשר ספירין
דיליה ובכל שמהן דיליה ומד׳
סמכין ושית דרגין דכורסייא
ומכל מארי מתיבתאן[iii] ומכל
מלאכייא ומכל פמיליי עלאי
ומכל פמיליי תתאי בעגלא
ובזמן קריב ויעלה ארוכה
לך וממכותיך ירפאך מנהורא
דעתיקא קדישא ויצמיח לך
ישועה בקרוב. וברחמיו הרבים
ירחם עליך עם כל חולי עמו
ישראל הצר כים לרחמים אמן
סלה ועד יהיו לרצון וגו׳: וקצת
משכילי עם כשהיה בהמ״ק קיים
בכניסתם לבקר החולה פעמים
הרבה היו אומרים זה חי וזה
מת וכל זה בהסתכלות ראשון
שהיו עושים בפניו תכף שנכנסים
בחדרו היה מתראה להם בפניו
אם חי או מת. וזהו ע״ד שאמרו
פרשת ויקהל דף ר״ז שהציץ

in turn receives from Tiferet, where healing and recovery come through the power of Keter Elyon.

This is the meaning of "Heal us, O Lord"—the name of Arikh Anpin (the Long-Faced One), where the essential intention lies, and healing flows through the three supernal sefirot to Chesed. The Crown (Keter) only influences the sefirot through the aspect of Chesed (Loving-kindness). "And we shall be healed" refers to below in Tiferet and Malkhut. The letters Nun and Vav represent the mystery of the souls of Israel that are attached to Tiferet (symbolized by Vav) and to Malkhut (symbolized by Nun), which need healing, and they are called "love-sick" in need of unification.[1]

If the sick person is a Torah scholar, his visiting friend should say over him: "May it be the will that you be blessed from the mouth of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence, in all His attributes, in His ten sefirot, in all His names, from the four pillars and six levels of His throne,[2] from all the masters of the academies, from all the angels, from all the supernal households, and from all the lower households, speedily and soon. May recovery come to you, and may He heal you from your wounds through the light of the Ancient Holy One, and may He cause salvation to spring forth for you soon. And in His abundant mercies, may He have compassion upon you together with all the sick of His people Israel who need mercy. Amen, Selah, and forever. May the words of my mouth be acceptable, etc."

Some of the wise among the people, when the Temple existed, upon entering to visit the sick, would often declare, "This one will live and this one will die"—all this from the first glance they made at the patient's face immediately upon entering his room;

[1] This references the kabbalistic concept that human souls yearn for mystical union with the divine, similar to lovers separated from their beloved, drawing on imagery from Song of Songs.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the divine throne being supported by six directions (corresponding to the six sefirot from Chesed to Yesod), which in turn corresponds to the six days of creation.

Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) to Malkhut (Kingdom), and from there to the angel Raphael who administers healing.

[i] This is a reference to Song of Songs 2:5 ('For I am sick with love'), interpreted kabbalistically to mean that the souls of Israel are 'lovesick' for divine unification.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means 'from the mouth of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence,' representing the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity in Kabbalah.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase refers to 'masters of the academies,' the heads of the heavenly yeshivot where the souls of the righteous study Torah after death.

נקרא כן לשון הסתכלות[i] שהכהן
היה מכיר בכח אותיות השם
70 שהיו חקוקי׳ בו בהסתכלות
הראשון אם האיש העומד לפניו
היה צדיק או רשע שהיה רואה
אור האותיות בפניו אבל אחר
כך כשהיה מסתכל לעיין בו לא
75 היה רואה בגין דחיזו עילאה לא
אתגלי אלא לפום שעתא[ii] והטבע
החכם הודיע לנו זה כי כשאדם
סותם עיניו קצת מתראה לפניו
דמות אורות רמז למרכבות
80 הנעלמות דלאו אינון אלא
בסתימו דעיינין וברגע בסוד
והחיות רצוא ושוב.[iii] ואגב זה
לא נניח מלבאר פי׳ כמראה
הבזק כאשר מצאתי בספר יצירה
85 והוא כי הצפייה שהספירות
צופות ומביטות זו בזו היא כאור
היוצא מבין החרסים פי׳ אילו
תקח חרס נקוב נקבים דקים על
פני כלו ותכסה בו האש ותנפח
90 במפוח באש עד שיתלהב ימשכו
מנתיבות הנקבים אשר בכל
נקב שבחרס חוטים ושלהביות
צבועות בכל מיני צבעים עולים
ויורדים בנתיבות הקטנים כן
95 צפיית החיות בנתיבות אל
החיות אשר למעלה מהם כי יש
כסא לכסא וכבוד לכבוד הנה
בצפייתם ישלחו נצוצי זוהר
בחשמל מיני צבעים[iv] ומתוך
100 פחדם מהסתכל בשכינה הם
רצים ושבים מהסתכל כמראה
הבזק שהוא נגלה ונעלם כהרף

it would appear to them in his face whether he would live or die.[1] This is similar to what is said in Parshat Vayakhel page 207 about the High Priest's headplate (tzitz), which is called thus from the term "looking," because the priest could recognize through the power of the Divine Name's letters engraved upon it, at first glance, whether the person standing before him was righteous or wicked. He would see the light of the letters in the person's face, but afterward, when he would look more carefully, he would no longer see this, because the supernal vision is only revealed momentarily. 70R 75R

Wise nature has taught us that when a person slightly closes his eyes, forms of light appear before him, alluding to the hidden chariots which exist only when the eyes are closed, and only for an instant, in the mystery of "the living creatures ran and returned" (Ezekiel 1:14). Incidentally, we should not omit explaining the meaning of "like the appearance of a flash" as I found in Sefer Yetzirah: The observation that the sefirot observe and look at one another is like light emerging from between pottery shards. That is, if you take a pottery shard with fine holes throughout its surface and cover fire with it, then blow into the fire with bellows until it blazes, there will extend from the pathways of the holes in each opening of the shard threads and flames colored with all kinds of colors, ascending and descending in small pathways. So is the gaze of the living creatures along the pathways to the living creatures above them, for there is a throne for each throne and honor for each honor.[2] In their gazing, they send sparks of radiance in the Chashmal of various colors, and out of their fear of looking at the Divine Presence, they run back and forth from looking, like the appearance of light- 80R 85R 90R 95R 100R

[1] This passage describes what today might be called medical intuition or diagnostic insight, but attributes it to mystical perception of divine light visible in the patient's face, comparable to the High Priest's spiritual discernment.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic principle that the divine realm contains hierarchical structures mirroring each other at different levels, with each level of reality being a reflection of the ones above it.

[i] The author connects the High Priest's headplate (tzitz) etymologically with the Hebrew word for gazing or looking (lehatzitz), emphasizing its mystical visual properties.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means 'because supernal vision is only revealed momentarily,' explaining why spiritual insight comes in flashes rather than sustained perception.

[iii] This quote from Ezekiel 1:14 describes the heavenly creatures (chayot) that 'ran and returned,' used here to illustrate the fleeting nature of mystical perception.

[iv] The Chashmal, mentioned in Ezekiel's vision, is interpreted in Kabbalah as a brilliant angelic substance composed of speaking fire, here described as containing colorful sparks of divine radiance.

עין או כחוטין שעולים ויורדים כהרף עין. מכאן אמרו בעלי
105 הסוד אם תראה אדם שמביט בך ומיד מביט לארץ וחוזר ומביט בך ומביט לארץ דע כי הוא מפחד ממך. ואם אינו לא סר מעליך ואינו מביט בארץ דע כי
110 הוא מבזה אותך בלבו ועל דרך זה נאמר כי לא יראני האדם וחי.[i] ואמרו חז״ל אפילו חיות הקדש:[ii]

ning that is revealed and hidden in the blink of an eye, or like threads that rise and fall in the blink of an eye. 105R

From here, the masters of mystical secrets said:[1] If you see a person who looks at you and immediately looks at the ground, then looks back at you and down again, know that he fears you. But if he does not turn away from you and does not look at the ground, know that he despises you in his heart. And in this vein it is said, "For no man shall see Me and live" (Exodus 33:20). And our Sages said: "Not even the holy living creatures."[2] 110R

ואמרו שם בזהר שכל עזי מצח
115 בשהיו מסתכלים בציץ[iii] היה נשבר לבם בקרבם והיה מכפר עליהם. וכן כל מי שהיה מריח בעשן הקטרת. ומיירי אחר שעלה

And they said there in the Zohar that all brazen-faced people,[3] when they looked at the headplate [of the High Priest], their hearts would break within them,[A] and it would atone for them.[4] Similarly, anyone who smelled the smoke of the incense [would 115R

[A] Or: "their hearts would be humbled within them" — While 'break' is the literal translation of 'נשבר', the metaphorical meaning here likely refers to the breaking of pride or arrogance, which could be rendered as 'humbled' to clarify the spiritual transformation being described.

[1] The author applies esoteric kabbalistic principles of mystical vision to everyday human interactions, suggesting that patterns of eye contact reveal one's spiritual relationship to others, just as celestial beings relate to divine light.

[2] This rabbinic extension of the biblical prohibition against seeing God emphasizes that even the highest angelic beings (the chayot or living creatures in Ezekiel's vision) cannot directly perceive the divine essence, reinforcing the limits of mystical perception at all levels of creation.

[3] The Hebrew term 'עזי מצח' (azei metzach) literally means 'those with a strong forehead' and is an idiom for people who are impudent, shameless, or arrogant. In this context, it refers to individuals whose spiritual state was corrupted by pride.

[4] The text presents a mystical understanding of atonement that occurs through visual interaction with sacred objects. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that sacred Temple items could effect spiritual transformation merely through sensory contact.

[i] This quote from Exodus 33:20 explains that direct divine vision is impossible for humans to survive, used here to illustrate why even celestial beings must avert their gaze from the Divine Presence.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parshat Shelach — The author cites this Zohar passage to establish the mystical understanding of illness as connected to demonic forces, particularly Lilith, who represents the feminine aspect of impurity. | Cf. Psalm 91:10-11 — These biblical verses are used as protective formulas when visiting the sick, with the author giving them kabbalistic interpretation relating to protection from demonic forces. | Cf. Saba (section of Zohar) — This reference connects the angel Raphael with divine healing powers, establishing a kabbalistic framework for understanding the spiritual mechanics of healing. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:14 — This biblical verse about divine vision is used to explain the fleeting nature of spiritual insight, particularly how mystical perception occurs in momentary flashes. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — This early kabbalistic text is cited to explain the complex interrelationships between the divine emanations (sefirot) through the metaphor of colored light shining through pottery. | Cf. Exodus 33:20 — This verse is applied to explain the mystical concept that direct divine vision is dangerous, requiring mediated perception through momentary glimpses rather than sustained gaze.

[iii] The tzitz was the golden headplate worn by the High Priest in the Temple, inscribed with the words 'Holy to the Lord.' According to rabbinic tradition, it had the power to atone for sins of arrogance.

תמרתו שבעת העלאתו היה חייב
מעילה[i] כי אין עבירה מצוה.
והגם שבפרק כל שעה[ii] אמרינן
קול ומראה וריח אין בהם
מעילה, אסורא דרבנן מיהא
איכא ובריח המותר ההוא
היה עובר ממנו זוהמא[iii] ולא
היה לו אלא לב אחד לאביו
שבשמים:[iv v]

be affected in this way].[A] This refers to after its column of smoke had risen, for during its rising one would be liable for misappropriation of sacred property (me'ilah), since a transgression is not a commandment.[1] And although in the chapter "Kol Sha'ah" we say that sound, sight, and smell do not constitute misappropriation, there is nevertheless a rabbinic prohibition. Through that permitted fragrance,[2] impurity would depart from him, and he would have only one heart directed toward his Father in heaven.[B]

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

אין לחולה לתלות סבת חליו
מחמת שום קרי[vi] בגון מאכל
או משקה ואפילו חבלוהו בני

The sick person should not attribute the cause of their illness to any chance occurrence, such as food or drink. Even if evil people have harmed them, they

[A] Or: "Similarly, anyone who inhaled the smoke of the incense [would experience this effect]" — The Hebrew verb 'מריח' specifically indicates smelling, but 'inhaled' might better convey the physical interaction with the incense smoke in this ritual context.

[B] Or: "and he would have a single-minded devotion to his Father in heaven" — The phrase 'לב אחד' (one heart) is an idiom suggesting undivided loyalty or single-minded devotion, which might be clearer in English with this alternate phrasing.

[1] This phrase appears to be a rabbinic principle explaining why one cannot fulfill a religious obligation through a prohibited act. Here it explains why the beneficial effects of the incense couldn't be experienced during the prohibited phase of the offering.

[2] The passage distinguishes between prohibited benefit from the incense during its active offering and permitted benefit after the smoke had risen, suggesting that even indirect exposure to Temple rituals could have purifying effects.

[i] Me'ilah refers to the prohibition against deriving personal benefit from consecrated Temple property. The text distinguishes between the prohibited stage of the incense offering (during its rising) and the permitted stage (after the column of smoke had formed).

[ii] This refers to a chapter in the Talmudic tractate Pesachim (26a) which discusses the laws of deriving benefit from consecrated items.

[iii] Zohama is a kabbalistic term for spiritual impurity or contamination that adheres to the soul. It is often described as originating from the primordial serpent in Eden and affecting humanity after Adam's sin.

[iv] The concept of having "one heart toward Heaven" appears in rabbinic literature as the ideal spiritual state of complete devotion, contrasted with a "divided heart" that is pulled toward worldly concerns.

[v] Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel — The reference to the Zohar comes from Parashat Vayakhel, which discusses how the High Priest's headplate revealed a person's spiritual state through divine illumination, causing the wicked to experience inner transformation when exposed to its holiness. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Pesachim — The citation of 'Kol Sha'ah' refers to a chapter in Tractate Pesachim that establishes the principle that deriving benefit from sound, sight, or smell of sacred items does not constitute me'ilah (misappropriation), though rabbinic prohibitions might still apply. | Cf. Keritot — While not directly quoted, this passage alludes to Talmudic discussions about the Temple incense that describe its purifying qualities, particularly its ability to remove spiritual impurity (zohama) and create spiritual unity in those who experienced it.

[vi] The Hebrew term 'keri' (קרי) has multiple meanings that create a rich theological wordplay here. It can mean 'chance/coincidence,' 'seminal emission,' or 'encounter.' The author is arguing against attributing illness to random chance rather than divine providence.

אדם הרעים יאמר כי עונותיו
גרמו לו בדכתיב אם תהיה רעה
בעיר וה׳ לא עשה.[i] וכן כתיב
תיסרך רעתך. ותמוגנו ביד
עוונינו. רוחכם אש תאכלכם וכל
התולה מאורעיו על צד הקרי
הוא נמשך אחר הכח הטומאה
שלצד צפון[ii] הנקרא קרי ומפתח
ההוא יוצא כח הרוגז ח״ו ואלה
הם המשוטטים בלילה[iii] ולכן
נקראים בעלי קרי:[iv] [v]

should say that their sins have caused this,[1] as it is written: "Shall there be evil in a city, and the Lord has not done it?" Similarly, it is written: "Your wickedness shall chastise you," and "We melt away in the hand of our iniquities," and "Your breath is a fire that shall consume you." Anyone who attributes their circumstances to chance is drawn after the power of impurity from the northern side,[2] which is called "chance" (keri), and from that opening emerges the power of anger, God forbid. These are the forces that wander at night, and therefore they are called "masters of chance."[3]

אם יש לחולה שום נדר יזהר
להתיר אותו והעומדים עליו
יזהירוהו על זה כי אמרו שאין
התרת נדרים מסורה למלאכי
השרת.[vi] ואולי כי דוקא אנשים

If the sick person has made any vow, he should be careful to annul it,[4] and those attending to him should warn him about this, for they said that the annulment of vows is not entrusted to the ministering angels. Perhaps this is because

[1] This reflects the common theological position in rabbinic Judaism that illness and suffering should be understood as divine correction rather than random misfortune, encouraging self-examination rather than blaming external causes.

[2] The translation simplifies complex kabbalistic terminology about the 'northern side' (צד צפון), which in Jewish mysticism represents the source of divine judgment and demonic forces, as opposed to the 'southern side' associated with divine mercy.

[3] The Hebrew 'ba'alei keri' (בעלי קרי) has a double meaning that's difficult to capture in English. It literally refers to men who have experienced nocturnal emissions (requiring ritual purification) but is used here metaphorically for those who attribute events to chance rather than divine providence. The author creates a wordplay connecting this ritual impurity with spiritual error.

[4] The Hebrew term "hatarat nedarim" refers to a formal process of annulling vows through a tribunal of three Jewish men (or one rabbi in some cases).

[i] From Amos 3:6, a verse often cited in rabbinic literature to support the theological principle that all events, including suffering, ultimately derive from divine providence.

[ii] In Kabbalistic cosmology, the northern side (tzad tzafon) is associated with demonic forces, impurity, and the left side of the divine system. This reflects the concept found in the Zohar that the north is the source of judgment and demonic forces.

[iii] This refers to demonic forces believed to be most active at night. The connection between 'keri' and nocturnal wandering may also allude to nocturnal emissions, considered spiritually problematic in rabbinic and kabbalistic thought.

[iv] The term 'ba'alei keri' traditionally refers to men who have experienced nocturnal emissions and thus require ritual purification. Here, the author creatively extends this term to those who attribute events to chance rather than divine providence, suggesting this attitude creates spiritual impurity.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Siftei Tzedek, Chapter on Suffering as Divine Correction — This passage builds on the earlier theological framework by addressing how the sick person should interpret their suffering—as divinely ordained rather than random chance. | Cf. Zohar — The text draws on kabbalistic cosmology from the Zohar that associates the northern direction with the sitra achra (other side) and demonic forces, contrasting with the south which represents divine mercy. | Cf. Talmud — The author is drawing on the rabbinic tradition that interprets suffering as a form of divine correction rather than random misfortune, encouraging the sick to examine their deeds rather than blaming external factors.

[vi] This is a rabbinic teaching found in the Talmud (Nedarim 10a). It means that only humans, not angels, have the authority to annul vows, emphasizing that this is a distinctly human religious power.

שהם בעלי בחירה[i] עוקרים האיסור מעל הנודר ומעמידים אותו בבחירתו כמאז ואין לחוש להתבטל מדברי תורה ומצוה כדי לבקר החולה דכתיב אשרי משכיל אל דל:[iii ii]

only humans, who possess free will, can remove the prohibition from the one who made the vow and restore him to his original state of choice.[C] And one should not be concerned about neglecting words of Torah and commandments in order to visit the sick, as it is written: "Happy is he who considers the poor."[1]

וראוי להודיע לחולה כי מי שלא ידע ביום טובה להצדיק רחמי שמים בכשרון המעשה. הנה מה טוב ומה נעים אם יצדק דין היסורים על עצמו ביום רעה. כדאמרו בב״ר על פסוק והנה טוב מאד זו מדת יסורים דכתיב ודרך חיים תוכחות מוסר וכתיב ואני יסרתי ובזה חזקתי זרועותם. ולאלה הצדיקים המקיימים בעצמם כך. יצדק בלי ספק שבמיתתם קרויים חיים עלייהו כתיב ומשביע לכל חי רצון כפי עילוי נשמתם באותה שעה להדבק ברצון העליון: וכתיב אך בשרו עליו יכאב ונפשו עליו תאבל למד על כל מי שאינו מתאבל על עצמו

The sick person should be informed that one who did not know how to justify God's mercy through proper conduct in times of good fortune would do well to justify the judgment of suffering upon himself[2] in times of hardship. As they said in Bereshit Rabbah on the verse "And behold, it was very good"—this refers to the attribute of suffering, as it is written, "The way of life is through disciplinary reproof" and "I have chastened them and strengthened their arms." For these righteous ones who fulfill this within themselves, it is undoubtedly true that in their death they are called living; of them it is written, "He satisfies every living thing with favor," according to the elevation of their souls at that time to cleave to the Supreme Will.

And it is written, "Yet his flesh shall feel pain, and his soul shall mourn over him." This teaches that whoever does not mourn over himself but rather over his sins, and rejoices in suffering for the glory

[C] Or: "This may be because specifically humans, as beings with free will, uproot the prohibition from the one who vowed and reestablish him in his original state of choice." — This alternate translation more literally renders the Hebrew terms "oqrim" (uproot) and "ke-me'az" (as before/originally), which carry specific connotations in Jewish legal discourse about returning a person to their pre-vow state.

[1] While the literal meaning of this verse refers to the poor, Jewish tradition interprets "dal" to include the sick, which is why this verse is cited as a justification for visiting the sick taking priority over Torah study.

[2] The Hebrew phrase "יצדק דין היסורים" literally means to "justify the judgment of sufferings," referring to the religious concept of accepting divine judgment as just, even when it brings suffering.

[i] The concept of "free will" (baalei bechirah) is significant in Jewish theology. The author suggests that humans' ability to annul vows stems from their possession of free will, which angels lack.

[ii] A quote from Psalm 41:2, which literally means "Happy is he who considers the poor." In this context, "dal" (poor) is interpreted to include the sick, suggesting that attending to the sick takes precedence over other religious obligations.

[iii] Cf. Talmud Nedarim 10a — The author cites this Talmudic principle to emphasize the human role in religious ritual, particularly regarding vows. This reference establishes the importance of human intervention for the sick person who needs vows annulled. | Cf. Talmud Nedarim 8a — While not directly quoted, this passage likely informs the author's emphasis on annulling vows for the sick. The Talmud suggests that unfulfilled vows can be a cause of illness, making their annulment potentially curative. | Cf. Psalm 41:2 — The author uses this verse to establish the priority of visiting the sick over other religious obligations, interpreting "dal" (poor) to include the sick, a common rabbinic interpretation.

אלא על עונותיו ושמח ביסורין
לכבוד שמים שבשרו לא יכאב
בחיי ובמותה. ומן השמים ירחמו
שלא ירגיש בצערו כמו המתים
לכבוד ה׳ שיוצאה נשמתם
במשחל ביניתא מחלבא: וכל
אדם הגם שמת על מטתו יכול
לקיים בעצמו כך למות על יחוד
קוב״ה ושכינתיה. ובפרט אם
כוון בתפלותיו ומצותיו ובפרט
בפרשת שמע ישראל ובשים
שלום ליחוד עליון ובנפילת
אפים למסור נפשו להשלים
היחוד והזיוג ובעת מיתתו על
יחוד שמו יתן שלמות והארה
רבה לכל אופני היחודים שפעל
ועשה כל ימי חייו וכן הוגד
למהר״רי קארו הרבה פעמים את
עתיד לאתוקדא על קדושת שמי
שנרמז לו כונת מיתתו גם שנפטר
בשם טוב על מטתו יעלוז חסיד
בכבוד: [i]

of Heaven[1]—his flesh will not feel pain in life or in death. Heaven will have mercy on him so that he will not feel his suffering, like those who die for the sanctification of God's name, whose souls depart like a fish drawn from milk.

And any person, even one who dies in his bed, can fulfill within himself the ability to die for the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence. Especially if he directed his prayers and commandments—particularly the Shema Yisrael recitation, the Sim Shalom blessing[2] for supreme unification, and the Nefilat Apayim prostration[3] to surrender his soul to complete the unification and divine coupling[4]—then at the time of his death, for the unification of His name, he will bring completion and great illumination to all the forms of unifications he effected and performed throughout his life. Thus it was foretold many times to Rabbi Joseph Karo, "You will be burned for the sanctification of My name," which hinted at the purpose of his death, even though he passed away with a good name in his bed—"Let the pious exult in glory."

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

אין לדבר בעון שעשה החולה
אלא לעצמו כדי שישוב בתשובה
ויפרש חטאיו לפני קונו: [ii] ובזהר

One should not speak about the sin that the sick person has committed except to the person themselves,[5] so that they may repent and specify their

[1] "For the glory of Heaven" (לכבוד שמים) is a Hebrew idiom meaning for God's honor or to sanctify God's name through one's actions.

[2] This refers to the final blessing of the Amidah prayer, which asks for peace. In kabbalistic interpretation, it represents divine unification.

[3] A prayer ritual involving bowing and covering one's face, performed after the Amidah. In mystical understanding, it symbolizes self-sacrifice and soul surrender to God.

[4] The term "זיוג" (coupling) in kabbalistic texts refers to the mystical union of divine attributes, particularly the masculine and feminine aspects of God (Tiferet and Malkhut).

[5] This ethical guideline reflects the Jewish value of avoiding lashon hara (evil speech) while still encouraging personal repentance. It balances pastoral care with respect for the sick person's dignity.

[i] Cf. Bereshit Rabbah 9:7 — The author uses this midrashic interpretation to establish a theological framework where suffering is understood as divinely ordained for spiritual benefit rather than random misfortune. | Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — The text cites this verse to support the theological claim that suffering serves as correction that leads to spiritual life rather than mere punishment. | Cf. Hosea 7:15 — This prophetic verse is cited to show that divine chastisement has a strengthening effect, supporting the text's positive view of suffering. | Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel 211b — The author draws on this Zoharic imagery to describe the ideal death experience for the righteous as a painless separation of soul from body. | Cf. Maggid Mesharim — The reference to Rabbi Karo receiving messages about being "burned for the sanctification of My name" likely comes from this mystical diary, though the author reinterprets this prediction spiritually since Karo died naturally.

[ii] This opening line establishes an important ethical principle for those visiting the sick: one should not publicly discuss the sick person's sins, but may speak privately with them to encourage repentance.

פרשת בא דף מ״א מתבאר צורך פרוט החטא דבהא ליח למקטרגא פטרא דפומא גביה ואתפרש מניה[i] אך אם חוזר לסורו מזכיר לו המקטרג כל העונות כי הודוי מושך הפגם מהמקומות העליונים למטה ובזה חותם פי השטן שלא יסטין[ii] מפני שמשפיע לו שפע וחלק התמצית הראוי להם ועוד שהקב״ה אומר לו מה לך עוד עמו. ובתפלות היום השכינה מקבלת אפילו חלק החצונים מלמעלה להשפיעם בלילה בסוד תפלת ערבית בעת שהיא מחלקת שלל לאגפיה[iii] והוא סוד המותר והשחרות והפגם הנעשה וזהו ויבאו בני האלהים וגו׳ ויבא גם השטן בתוכם ליקח חלקו. ואז״ל כי ביחוד תפלת שחרית ומנחה שהם בסוד חבוק ב׳ דרועין[iv] מקבלת חלק הקדושה והשחרות מתרחק בודוי האדם בסוד אור י״ג מדות עליונות[v] ויורד מדרגה אחר מדרגה עד למטה ומשם

sins before their Creator. In the Zohar, Parashat Bo, page 41, the necessity of detailing one's sin is explained, for in this way the accuser has no opening to speak against them, and separates from them. However, if one returns to their sinful ways, the accuser reminds them of all their iniquities, because confession draws the spiritual blemish down from the upper realms,[1] thereby sealing the mouth of Satan so he cannot prosecute, since [through confession] one channels to him the appropriate flow and portion that is due to him.[2] Furthermore, the Holy One, blessed be He, says to him, "What more do you want with him?"

During the daytime prayers, the Divine Presence receives even the portion of the external forces from above, to channel it to them at night through the mystery of the evening prayer, when She distributes spoils to her legions.[3] This is the secret of the excess, the darkness, and the blemish that is created, as it is written: "The sons of God came, etc., and Satan came also among them" to take his portion. Our Sages taught that through the unification of the morning and afternoon prayers, which represent the embrace of the two arms,[4] She receives the portion of holiness, and the darkness is distanced through a person's confession, through the light of the thir-

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that human actions have cosmic consequences. Confession is not merely psychological but causes actual metaphysical changes in spiritual realms.

[2] This presents a sophisticated theological concept: rather than simply eliminating negative forces, confession properly channels their energy to its appropriate place in the cosmic order.

[3] The Divine Presence (Shekhinah) is portrayed in feminine terms, consistent with kabbalistic tradition. Her distribution of spiritual energies during evening prayer represents the cosmic balance between day (dominance of holiness) and night (when external forces receive their portion).

[4] This metaphor reveals how prayer is understood in physical, anthropomorphic terms, with morning and afternoon prayers representing a cosmic embrace that unifies different divine attributes.

[i] The Aramaic phrase "ליח למקטרגא פטרא דפומא גביה" means "the accuser has no opening of the mouth against him." This reflects the kabbalistic belief that confessing sins prevents spiritual accusers from using those sins against the person in heavenly judgment.

[ii] This expresses the kabbalistic concept that confession (vidui) has metaphysical effects, literally drawing spiritual blemishes downward from higher realms, which neutralizes Satan's ability to act as prosecutor in the divine court.

[iii] This passage reflects the kabbalistic view that the daily prayer cycle participates in cosmic processes where the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) manages the distribution of spiritual energies, including portions given to the "external forces" (forces of impurity) during evening prayer.

[iv] The morning and afternoon prayers are described as "the embrace of two arms" (the right and left arms), which in Kabbalah represents the unification of divine attributes of kindness (right) and judgment (left).

[v] The "light of the thirteen supernal attributes" refers to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, which in Kabbalah represent divine compassion that can overcome judgment and are invoked in prayers for forgiveness.

נזון החצוני ויש לו ידים להיות נמשך דרך צנור מיוחד לבל יתערב בחלק הקדושה[i] ומשם יורד להנתן במצולות ים למקום הראוי לו ואם ח״ו חוזר לסורו אחר שהתודה חוזרים העונות שהשפיע מקודם לחצונים ונעורים למעלה ומסתלקי׳ משם למעלה ח״ו וזהו כונת ספר הזהר פר׳ פקודי דאמר נטלי לון מההוא סטרא בעל כרחיה וחיל בלע ויקיאנו.[ii] ולזה מקטרג. והוסיף להודיע לנו בפרשה בא בדף הנ״ל כח ההבל הקדוש העולה מפי האדם כי הוא להב אש קדוש וטהור[iii] העולה בסוד כח רוחניות הב׳ צורות קדושות הה׳ אותיות ע״י חמש מוצאות שהם מחסד עד הוד[iv] בכח נשמת הנקודות. קצת מהם על האותיות. מהם בתוכיותן. מהם למטן. בסוד ה׳ מלכים שהם הספירות במקומן וה׳ עבדים שהוא מציאותן במלכות למטה.[v] והשב״א עבד עבדים והוא עבד משכיל מושל

teen supernal attributes.[1] It descends level by level until it reaches the bottom, and from there the external force is nourished. It has "hands" to be drawn through a special channel so as not to intermingle with the portion of holiness, and from there it descends to be cast into the depths of the sea, to the place appropriate for it. 30R 35R

If, heaven forbid, one returns to their sinful ways after having confessed, the sins that were previously channeled to the external forces return and are awakened above,[2] and ascend from there upwards, heaven forbid. This is the intention of the Zohar in Parashat Pekudei, which states: "They take them from that side against its will, and 'the wealth he has swallowed he will vomit up.'" For this reason, he accuses. 40R

The Zohar further informs us in Parashat Bo on the aforementioned page about the power of the sacred breath that rises from a person's mouth,[3] for it is a holy and pure flame that rises through the mystery of the spiritual power of the two holy forms of the five letters through the five points of articulation, which extend from Chesed to Hod[4] through the power of the soul of the vowel points. Some of them are above the letters, some within them, and some below them, through the mystery of the five kings, which are the Sefirot in their places, and the five 45R 50R 55R

[1] The Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7) are invoked during confession, and are understood here as actual divine light that transforms and redirects negative spiritual energies.

[2] This presents the serious kabbalistic understanding of backsliding after confession—it doesn't merely return one to their previous state but actively worsens their spiritual condition by reactivating sins that had been neutralized.

[3] The Hebrew term 'hevel' (breath) connects to Genesis where God breathes life into humans. In Kabbalah, human breath in prayer is understood as a holy substance with actual power to ascend through spiritual realms.

[4] This passage correlates physical speech production with the structure of divine attributes (Sefirot), showing how the kabbalistic worldview integrates physical, psychological, and metaphysical dimensions into a unified system.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that even negative forces have a legitimate place in the divine order and must receive their sustenance, but through designated channels that prevent them from interfering with holiness.

[ii] This is a quote from Job 20:15, "He swallows wealth, but will vomit it up," used here to describe how external forces must relinquish what they have taken when a person repents.

[iii] This portrays human speech, particularly in prayer, as literally creating holy fire that ascends through spiritual realms, emphasizing the power and importance of confession and prayer.

[iv] The "five points of articulation" refers to the five places in the mouth where Hebrew letters are formed (throat, palate, tongue, teeth, and lips), which are correlated here with five of the lower Sefirot: Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netzach, and Hod.

[v] This describes how the five Sefirot (Chesed through Hod) exist both in their own place (as "kings") and as they are reflected in the lowest Sefirah of Malkhut (as "servants"), creating a mirror relationship between upper and lower realms.

לפעמים.[i] וכל רוחניות הנזכר מתעורר בכח הבל האדם בשירי זמרה ותפלה:[ii]

servants, which are their manifestation in Malkhut below. The Sheva is the servant of servants, yet it is a wise servant that sometimes rules. All the spirituality mentioned is awakened through the power of human breath in songs, hymns, and prayer. 60R

ואמר שבסיפור יציאת מצרים בכל יום ישראל יהבי חילא למריהון דאתוסף גבורתיה כד משבחן גבורתיה וכלהו דחלין מיניה וספור גאולה זו הוא הכנה לביאת משיח צדקנו.[iii] כי יציאת מצרים היה מסטרא דיובלא שהיא בחינת הבינה בגבורה[iv] דהיינו אילו של יצחק ומשם נמשך גאולה בלתי שלימה ולכן גאולת מצרי׳ לא היתה שלימה. אמנם יש שופר גדול שהוא בחינת

He said that when Israel recounts the Exodus from Egypt every day, they give strength to their Master,[1] increasing His might as they praise His power, and all fear Him. This recounting of redemption is a preparation for the coming of our righteous Messiah. For the Exodus from Egypt came from the side of the Jubilee, which is the aspect of Binah within Gevurah,[A] namely the ram of Isaac, and from there flowed an incomplete redemption. Therefore, the redemption from Egypt was not complete. However, there is a great shofar, which is the aspect of Binah within Chokhmah, from which it is great from the side of Gedulah, the kindness of Abraham, and 65R 70R

[A] Or: "the Exodus from Egypt emanated from the aspect of Jubilee, representing Understanding (Binah) within the sefirah of Strength (Gevurah)" — This alternative provides more explicit explanation of the kabbalistic terms, making it clearer to readers unfamiliar with these concepts.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that human actions and prayers have the power to strengthen divine attributes. The Aramaic phrase 'יהבי חילא למריהון' conveys the idea that humans can actually augment divine power through proper spiritual actions.

[i] The Sheva (a Hebrew vowel point) is described as the "servant of servants," yet paradoxically as a "wise servant that sometimes rules," reflecting the kabbalistic principle that even the lowest elements contain hidden power and significance.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Bo, folio 41 — The author uses this Zohar passage as the primary source for explaining the cosmic mechanics of confession and its effects on both the confessing person and the broader spiritual realms, establishing the metaphysical rationale for the Jewish practice of confession (vidui). | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The author cites this to explain the consequences of returning to sin after confession, showing how this creates a spiritual deficit by forcing the reactivation of sins that had been properly channeled. | Cf. Book of Job 20:15 — The author applies this verse metaphorically to describe how external spiritual forces must surrender the spiritual energy they received through a person's sins when that person confesses properly. | Cf. Jewish liturgy—Daily prayer cycle — The author provides a kabbalistic interpretation of the standard Jewish prayer cycle, explaining how each prayer service has a specific cosmic function in managing the flow of spiritual energies between divine and negative forces. | Cf. Kabbalistic doctrine of the Sefirot — The author integrates the structure of the Sefirot with the mechanics of human speech and prayer, showing how the physical act of confession creates ripples through the entire divine system. | Cf. Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7) — The author portrays these attributes as actual spiritual light that transforms negative energies during confession, connecting Biblical theology with kabbalistic practice.

[iii] This establishes a mystical connection between the daily recounting of the Exodus and the future messianic redemption, suggesting that the former actively prepares for the latter through spiritual channels.

[iv] The text presents a kabbalistic analysis of the Exodus using the language of sefirot (divine emanations). It associates the Exodus with 'Jubilee' (the 50th year in the biblical cycle), which represents Binah (Understanding) operating through Gevurah (Judgment/Strength), explaining why this redemption was imperfect.

הבינה בחכמה[i] שמשם הוא
גדול מסטרא דגדולה חסד
אברהם ומתמן מתערין רחמי
לא דינין והתוקע השופר הזה
לגאולה היא החכמה[ii] ומשם
ימשך הגאולה ברחמים גדולים
שאין אחריו גלות. ועכ״פ הזכרת
יציאת מצרים היא התעוררות
לעתיד לא כביאה שרה ובפ׳
בשלח דף מ״ח באר איך בנסי
מצרים איתבר חילא מכל קומת
החצונים על כן חובה על כל
בר נש לאשתעויי תדיר קמיה
קב״ה בכל נסי דעבד ליה
כי נס הוא התעוררות היסוד
ונפלאות הם גלוי הבינה בחמשים
שערים[iii] בהיותה נאחזת בחכמה
וכתר. עוד בדבר אחר מתעלה
כבוד ה׳ ומחליש כח החצונים
וזה על ידי מי שמתעסק בעולם
הזה להחזיר הרשעים בתשובה.
וכתיב בפרשת תרומה דף קכ״ח
ב״ט שאין מצוה רצויה למעלה
יותר מזו. כי ראשונה מחליש
כח סטרא אחרא וגורם שיתעלה
הקב״ה בכבודו ומקיים כל

from there mercy is aroused, not judgments. The one who blows this shofar for redemption is Chokhmah (Wisdom),[A] and from there will flow the redemption with great mercies that will not be followed by exile.[1] In any case, the remembrance of the Exodus from Egypt is an awakening for the future, not like the coming of Sarah.[2] And in Parshat Beshalach page 48, it explains how through the miracles of Egypt, the power of all the structure of the external forces was broken. Therefore, it is an obligation upon every person to constantly recount before the Holy One, blessed be He, all the miracles He performed for him, for a miracle is an awakening of Yesod, and wonders are a revelation of Binah in the fifty gates,[3] when it is connected to Chokhmah and Keter.

Additionally, in another way, the glory of God is elevated and the power of the external forces is weakened, and this is through one who occupies himself in this world with returning the wicked to repentance.[4] And it is written in Parshat Terumah page 128-129 that there is no commandment more desirable above than this one. For first, it weakens the power of the Other Side and causes the Holy One, blessed be He, to be elevated in His glory, and sustains the entire world above and below. Such a person sees children for his children and merits both

[A] Or: "The divine attribute of Wisdom (Chokhmah) is what sounds this shofar for redemption" — This clarifies that Chokhmah is not a person blowing the shofar but rather the divine attribute itself that activates the redemptive process.

[1] The text distinguishes between the historical Exodus (which was followed by later exiles) and the future messianic redemption, which is described as permanent and complete. This reflects the traditional Jewish belief in an ultimate redemption that will permanently end exile.

[2] This puzzling phrase might be a scribal error or an obscure reference. It could refer to Sarah's temporary residence in Egypt (Genesis 12) as a contrast to the complete redemption, or it may allude to some teaching about Sarah that was known to the author's contemporaries.

[3] The text offers a kabbalistic distinction between different types of divine interventions. 'Miracle' (nes) connects to Yesod, the sefirah that channels divine flow into our world, while 'wonders' (nifla'ot) connect to Binah operating through its '50 gates,' representing higher forms of revelation.

[4] The text identifies helping others repent as the highest spiritual achievement, surpassing all other commandments. This reflects a core theme in Jewish mysticism that interpersonal spiritual assistance has profound cosmic effects.

[i] This refers to the 'great shofar' mentioned in Isaiah 27:13 that will herald the messianic redemption. The text interprets this eschatologically, explaining that the final redemption will come through Binah (Understanding) working through Chokhmah (Wisdom) rather than through Gevurah (Judgment).

[ii] Unlike a human blowing a physical shofar, this refers to the divine attribute of Wisdom (Chokhmah) itself activating the redemptive process through cosmic channels.

[iii] The text distinguishes between 'nes' (miracle) and 'nifla'ot' (wonders) in kabbalistic terms: miracles correspond to the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation), while wonders correspond to Binah (Understanding) operating through its 'fifty gates,' a concept found in rabbinic literature referring to the highest levels of spiritual insight.

העולם למעלה ולמטה ורואה
בנים לבניו ויזכה לעוה״ז
ולעוה״ב. וכל בעלי דינין אינם
יכולים לדונו לא בעוה״ז ולא
בעוה״ב. ונכנס בי״ג שערים
ואין מוחה בידו.[i] ומעמידין
דיוקנו לפני המלך העליון
והוא מבורך בכל הברכות
שנתברך אברהם כשעשה אותו
הנפש בחרן. ומצאתי כי חרן
היה מקום מוכן להביא גרים
תחת כנפי השכינה יותר ממקום
אחר.[ii] והיא בגימטריא ג׳ פעמים
אלהים שאברהם מיתק שם כל
הדינים הקשים.[iii] ובזווג אברהם
עם אשתו לא יגע לריק כאדם
הראשון בק״ל שנה.[iv] וכן חוה
אמרו במדרש רבה כי על כן
נקראת אימא של כל החיים. על
כן אמרו דאית רוחין דביתא
ורוחין דחקלא.[v] אבל אברהם
ושרה טפות שלהם נתלבשו בהם
נשמות. ולכן אברהם נקרא אב
המון גוים ושרה מגיירת הנשים
וזהו הנפש אשר עשו בחרן דוקא
כדאמרו בפרשה תרומה דף
קמ״ו. והיו תקון ראשון של

this world and the World to Come. No masters of judgment can judge him, neither in this world nor in the World to Come. He enters through the thirteen gates with none to protest, and his image is established before the Supernal King.[1] He is blessed with all the blessings with which Abraham was blessed when he made those souls in Haran.

I found that Haran was a place prepared to bring converts under the wings of the Divine Presence more than any other place. Its numerical value equals three times Elohim, for Abraham sweetened all the harsh judgments there. And in Abraham's union with his wife, he did not labor in vain like Adam in the 130 years. And likewise regarding Eve, they said in Midrash Rabbah that she is called "mother of all living." Therefore they said that there are spirits of the house and spirits of the field. But Abraham and Sarah's drops were clothed with souls. Therefore Abraham is called the father of many nations, and Sarah converted the women, and this is "the souls that they made in Haran,"[2] precisely as they said in Parshat Terumah page 147. They were the first rectification of Adam and his wife,[3] and what they damaged, Abraham and Sarah repaired in the aspect of one part of the souls of Adam and Eve. For the other two parts were rectified through Isaac and Rebecca, and Jacob and his wives.[4] He also rectified

[1] This suggests that one who helps others repent receives the honor of having their spiritual image or form permanently established in the divine presence, a profound mystical reward.

[2] This interprets Genesis 12:5 ('the souls that they had made in Haran') as referring to Abraham and Sarah's conversion of others. Traditional Jewish interpretation understands this verse as indicating that Abraham and Sarah brought others to monotheistic faith.

[3] The text presents Abraham and Sarah's spiritual work as a cosmic repair (tikkun) of the damage caused by Adam and Eve's sin. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that later biblical figures rectify aspects of Adam's original sin.

[4] According to this kabbalistic interpretation, each of the patriarchs and matriarchs repaired dif-

[i] The 'thirteen gates' likely refers to the thirteen attributes of divine mercy. The passage suggests that one who returns others to repentance gains special access to these divine channels of mercy without opposition.

[ii] This presents a mystical geography where certain physical locations have spiritual properties. Haran is portrayed as having special qualities for converting souls, which explains why Abraham and Sarah were particularly successful there.

[iii] This uses gematria (Hebrew numerology) to explain Haran's spiritual significance. The name חרן equals 258, which is 3 times the value of אלהים (86), the divine name associated with judgment. Abraham's spiritual work there 'sweetened' (transformed) these judgments into mercy.

[iv] This references the rabbinic tradition that Adam separated from Eve for 130 years after their sin (based on Genesis 5:3), during which time his emissions produced demonic spirits. In contrast, Abraham and Sarah's union was always spiritually productive.

[v] This Aramaic phrase distinguishes between 'spirits of the house' and 'spirits of the field,' referring to the kabbalistic belief that Adam's emissions during his separation from Eve produced different types of demons, contrasted with Abraham and Sarah's spiritually productive union.

אדם ואשתו ומה שפגמו הם תקנו
אברהם ושרה בבחינת חלק אחד
מנשמתם של אדם וחוה. כי הב׳
חלקים אחרים נתקנו ע״י יצחק
ורבקה ויעקב וזוגותיו ותקן
ג״כ בני קטורה במסירת להם
שם טומאה[i] כאשר נבאר לקמן
שאינם דברים כפשטן. ובסוף
דברי הזהר אמר כי אין שכר
המגיע לשברן של אלו ואלמלא
הוו ידעי בני נשא דא הוו רדפי
בתר דא כמאן דרדיף בתר חיין
וזו רפואה גדולה לחוטא להשיב
רבים מעון. עוד ממעלת חשב
כי מעלת הלהב העולה משברון
רוחו בפרוט עונותיו מלבד
שמגדיל כח הקדושה עוד מחליש
כח הטומאה על דרך אם רעב
שונאך האכילהו לחם ואם צמא
השקהו מים הראויים להם שהם
העונות.[ii] כי אין זה כבוד אליו
אלא גחלים אתה חותה על ראשו
כעין גחלי רתמים ונהר דינור

the children of Keturah by giving them a name of impurity, as we will explain later, that these matters are not according to their plain meaning.

At the end of the Zohar's words, it states that no reward reaches the reward of these people, and if people knew this, they would pursue it like one who pursues life.[A1] This is a great healing for the sinner, to turn many from iniquity. Another merit of the one who repents is that the flame rising from his broken spirit in detailing his sins, besides increasing the power of holiness, also weakens the power of impurity, as in "If your enemy is hungry, feed him bread, and if he is thirsty, give him water" appropriate for them, which are the sins. For this is not honor to him, but rather "you heap coals of fire upon his head,"[2] like coals of broom trees and the river of fire made from the sweat of the Holy Beasts[3] that flows to Gehenna. This is the secret of Haman being invited to the feast that Esther made, and the secret of the "feast of rich foods, a feast of aged wines"[4] written in Isaiah. In this way, they are "mute dogs that cannot bark."[5] The breaking of his spirit in confession is certainly "the sacrifices of God."[6] Therefore,

[A] Or: "like one who chases after eternal life" — This idiomatic Aramaic expression could be rendered more explicitly to emphasize the spiritual dimension of 'life' being pursued, as it refers to spiritual rather than merely physical existence.

ferent aspects of Adam and Eve's sin, with Abraham and Sarah addressing one dimension, Isaac and Rebecca another, and Jacob and his wives yet another.

[1] This emphasizes that if people truly understood the spiritual merit of helping others repent, they would eagerly seek opportunities to do so, recognizing it as the path to the highest spiritual attainment.

[2] This creatively reinterprets Proverbs 25:21-22 in a mystical context. Just as feeding an enemy paradoxically places 'coals on their head,' confessing sins to God paradoxically weakens rather than strengthens the negative spiritual forces associated with those sins.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'nehar dinur' (river of fire), which is described in the mystical literature as formed from the perspiration of the holy creatures (chayot) that bear the divine throne, as described in Ezekiel's vision.

[4] This quotes Isaiah 25:6, which describes the messianic banquet at the end of days. The text creates a complex mystical parallel between Esther's feast (which led to Haman's downfall), Isaiah's messianic banquet, and the confession of sins.

[5] This quotes Isaiah 56:10, where it describes negligent spiritual leaders. Here it's applied to negative spiritual forces that are rendered powerless ('mute') through proper confession.

[6] This refers to Psalm 51:19, 'The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit,' suggesting that the contrition expressed in confession serves as a spiritual sacrifice that replaces the physical sacrifices offered in the Temple.

[i] This refers to Abraham's children with Keturah (Genesis 25:1-6). The text suggests Abraham performed a spiritual rectification by giving them 'a name of impurity,' possibly referring to his sending them away from Isaac with gifts, which kabbalists interpreted as containing elements of controlled impurity.

[ii] The text creatively reinterprets Proverbs 25:21-22, suggesting that when one confesses sins, one 'feeds' one's spiritual enemies (negative forces) their appropriate 'food' (the acknowledged sins), which paradoxically weakens them rather than strengthens them.

הנעשה מזיעתן של חיות הנמשך לגיהנם. והיינו סוד המן אל המשתה אשר עשתה אסתר.[i] וסוד משתה שמנים משתה שמרים הכתוב בישעיה ובזה הם כלבים אלמים שלא יוכלו לנבוח. ושברון רוחו בודוי הם זבחי אלהים ודאי. ולכן חלמא בישא עציבותיה מסתייהו[ii] תו לא שליט דינא עלוהי דזבח דאתחזי למדת דינא אקריב גביה:[iii]

the distress of a bad dream is sufficient; judgment no longer rules over him, for he has offered a sacrifice that is fitting for the attribute of judgment. 150R

ואם יעלה הבל זה מתוך דמעה[iv] ובפרט למוטל על ערש דוי ששכינה למעלה מראשו[v] ודאי כי בפיו יומתקו מליו ויקובל ברצון. ולית מפתחא דלא תבר ההוא דתב בתיובתא.[vi] ומתברא כל

And if this breath [of confession][1] rises amidst tears, especially from one lying on a sickbed with the Divine Presence above his head,[2] surely his words will be sweetened in his mouth and accepted favorably. There is no gate that will not be broken[3] by one who returns in repentance, and all decrees and judgments are shattered, along with many chains of iron,[4] and 155R

[1]The original Hebrew term 'hevel' (הבל) means breath or vapor and refers to the confession mentioned in the previous passage. I added '[of confession]' for clarity.

[2]This refers to the Jewish belief that the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) hovers above a sick person's bed, making their prayers especially potent.

[3]The original uses Aramaic metaphorical language describing repentance as a force that can break through all spiritual barriers or gates that might otherwise prevent one's prayers from ascending to heaven.

[4]These metaphors describe divine punishments or consequences of sin that are canceled through

[i]This creates a mystical interpretation of Esther inviting Haman to her feast, suggesting it parallels how confession offers sins to the negative forces, ultimately leading to their downfall rather than empowerment.

[ii]This Aramaic phrase comes from the Talmud (Berakhot 55b) and means 'for a bad dream, its sadness is sufficient.' The text applies this principle to confession of sins, suggesting that the distress of acknowledgment itself serves as atonement.

[iii]Cf. Zohar, Beshalach — The text directly references this Zohar passage to establish the cosmic significance of recounting the Exodus, showing how it weakens negative spiritual forces and prepares for the ultimate redemption. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah — This reference establishes the author's view on the highest spiritual achievement—helping others repent—by citing the Zohar's detailed explanation of the cosmic benefits and eternal rewards for this action. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah — This reference supports the author's kabbalistic interpretation of Abraham and Sarah's role in rectifying Adam and Eve's sin through their work converting others. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah on Genesis — The author uses this midrashic interpretation to compare Eve's motherhood with Sarah's spiritual motherhood through conversion, establishing a pattern of rectification. | Cf. Proverbs 25:21-22 — The author creatively reinterprets this verse in a mystical context, suggesting that confession and repentance 'feed' the negative forces their appropriate nourishment (sins), which paradoxically weakens them like coals of fire on the head. | Cf. Isaiah 25:6 — The author creates a complex mystical interpretation connecting Esther's feast (to which Haman was invited), Isaiah's messianic banquet, and the confession of sins as ways of weakening negative spiritual forces.

[iv]The term 'hevel' (breath/vapor) refers to the confession mentioned in the previous passage. In Kabbalistic thought, the breath of prayer and confession has spiritual substance that ascends through cosmic realms.

[v]This references the Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 12b) that the Divine Presence hovers above the head of a sick person, creating a particularly sacred space for prayer and confession.

[vi]This is in Aramaic: "There is no gate that is not broken by one who returns in repentance." The metaphor portrays repentance as a force capable of breaking through all spiritual barriers.

גזירין ודינין וכמה שלשלאין דפרזלא[i] ולית מאן דקיימא קמי תשובה.[ii] אך צריך לעשותה בעודו בתקפו כי לא לאיש הולך וחכין את צעדו.[iii] ויהי מה יפה לעולם תשובה ואפי׳ אחר גזר דין.[iv] עיין בסבא דף ק״ו.[v] ושם פירשו ואשלם נחומים לו ולאבליו.[vi] ונקרא בעל תשובה משום דאחיד באילן החיים דביה תליא תשובה.[vii] וע״ד אין צדיקים גמורים יכולים לעמוד במקומו:[viii][ix]

nothing can stand before repentance. However, one must perform it while still in full strength, for it is not for one who is departing to prepare his steps. Whatever happens, repentance is always beautiful for the world, even after the decree has been sealed.[1] See the Sabba [Zohar section] page 106,[2] where they explain [the verse] "And I will restore comfort to him and to his mourners." One is called a master of repentance because he grasps the Tree of Life, in which repentance depends.[3] And regarding this, even the completely righteous cannot stand in his place.[4] 160R 165R 170R

פרק ה׳

Chapter 5

וכמו שאין להזכיר עונות Just as one should not mention the sins of a sick

sincere repentance. The 'chains of iron' represent spiritual bondage caused by sin.

[1]This references the Jewish concept that even after God has sealed a judgment against someone (particularly during the High Holidays), sincere repentance can still reverse it.

[2]The 'Sabba' refers to a section of the Zohar called 'Sabba d'Mishpatim' (The Elder of Mishpatim), which contains mystical teachings about repentance and the soul.

[3]In Kabbalistic thought, the Tree of Life refers to the sefirah of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), which is associated with the attribute of mercy. True repentance connects one to this divine attribute.

[4]This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Berakhot 34b) that those who overcome sin through repentance achieve a higher spiritual level than those who never sinned at all.

[i]Another Aramaic phrase describing how repentance shatters divine decrees (gzirin), judgments (dinin), and "chains of iron" (shalshela'in d'farzela)—metaphors for harsh spiritual consequences that would otherwise bind the sinner.

[ii]Aramaic: "And nothing can stand before repentance." This emphasizes the supreme spiritual power of genuine repentance.

[iii]This phrase plays on Proverbs 16:9 ("A man's heart plans his way, but the Lord directs his steps") to emphasize that deathbed repentance may be too late for proper spiritual preparation.

[iv]This references the rabbinic teaching that repentance can overturn even a sealed divine decree, a concept particularly important in the context of illness and approaching death.

[v]This refers to a section of the Zohar known as "Sabba d'Mishpatim" (The Elder of Mishpatim), folio 106, which contains teachings about repentance and the soul.

[vi]A quotation from Isaiah 57:18, which in context refers to God's healing and comforting those who repent. The author is referencing the Zohar's interpretation of this verse.

[vii]Aramaic: "because he grasps the Tree of Life in which repentance depends." This is a kabbalistic concept linking repentance to the sefirah of Tiferet, often associated with the Tree of Life.

[viii]This references the Talmudic teaching (Berakhot 34b) that "In the place where penitents stand, even the completely righteous cannot stand," suggesting that those who overcome sin through repentance achieve a higher spiritual level than those who never sinned.

[ix]Cf. Talmud, Shabbat 12b — The author references this Talmudic teaching to emphasize why confessions and prayers of the sick are particularly potent—they occur in the immediate presence of the Divine. | Cf. Talmud, Berakhot 34b — The author quotes this Talmudic teaching to emphasize the extraordinary spiritual power of repentance, particularly when performed while seriously ill, as it elevates the penitent to heights even the perfectly righteous cannot reach. | Cf. Zohar, Sabba d'Mishpatim — The author cites this Zoharic passage to provide mystical depth to his teaching about repentance, connecting the act of confession during illness to cosmic structures and divine attributes in Kabbalistic thought. | Cf. Isaiah 57:18 — The author cites this verse as interpreted in the Zohar to demonstrate that genuine repentance, especially when accompanied by tears, leads to divine comfort and healing for both the individual and those connected to them.

החולה. גם כן לאשה המקשה לילד דריע מזלא אין להזכיר עונה. וראיתי כי לאשה המקשה לילד מביאים לה ע״י בעלה נר של בית הכנסת[i] ומשתדלים עמה שהיא בעצמה תדליק אותה וזה כדי להזכיר לה זכות הדלקת הנר שחובה עליה להתפלל בהדלקת נ״ש ויו״ט ויום הכפורים על חיי בעלה ועל בניה שיזכו לתורה כדאמרי׳ בזהר וכן היא תהרהר אז בתשובה על ג׳ עבירות שעליהם נשים מתות בשעת לדתן.[ii] וראוי לאשה שתזהר בימי עבורה שלא ללכת וגם לא להסתכל במקום עבירה וכ״ש שתשמור עצמה מכל טינוף חטא יען כי העובר במעיה צופה ומביט ויודע הרבה כההיא עובדא דר׳ יהושע בן חנניה[iii] ודומיהן, והנשים צריכות ג״כ זהירות לענין חייהם מפני שהם למטה באילנא דמותא והם בבחינה זו בעין דוד שלא

person, similarly for a woman having difficulty in childbirth—whose fortune is compromised[A]—one should not mention her sin.[1] I have observed that for a woman struggling in childbirth, they bring her, through her husband, a candle from the synagogue and encourage her to light it herself. This is to remind her of the merit of candle-lighting, which is her obligation, and to pray during the lighting of Sabbath and festival candles and on Yom Kippur for her husband's life and for her children that they may merit Torah study, as stated in the Zohar. She should also reflect then on repentance regarding the three transgressions for which women die during childbirth.[2]

It is proper for a pregnant woman to be careful not to walk or even look at places of transgression, and certainly to guard herself from any taint of sin, because the fetus in her womb observes, watches, and knows much,[3] as in that story about Rabbi Joshua ben Hananiah and similar accounts. Women also need to be vigilant regarding their lives because they are positioned below on the Tree of Death,[B] and in this respect they are like David who had no life of his own.[4] To attain the supernal life, they need to guard

[A] Or: "whose astrological fortune is weakened" — The term 'mazla' (מזלא) specifically refers to astrological fortune or destiny in kabbalistic literature. This translation more explicitly captures the astrological connotation, which might be helpful for readers unfamiliar with kabbalah.

[B] Or: "on the Tree of Mortality" — 'Tree of Death' is the literal translation, but 'Tree of Mortality' might better convey the kabbalistic concept referring to the sefirotic position associated with finitude and limitation, contrasting with the 'Tree of Life.'

[1] This reflects the traditional belief that speaking about sin during times of danger might summon divine judgment. There was a particular concern about mentioning sins during childbirth, which was considered a time of judgment for women.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 31b-32a) that women are at risk during childbirth for negligence in three specific commandments assigned to them: niddah (family purity), challah (separating dough), and hadlakat ha-ner (candle lighting).

[3] This reflects the belief that an unborn child has spiritual awareness and is influenced by the mother's actions and environments. This concept appears in various rabbinic sources and influenced customs regarding pregnant women's behavior.

[4] This refers to the midrashic tradition that David's 70 years of life were actually given to him from Adam's original allotment. In Kabbalah, this represents how the feminine aspect of divinity

[i] The practice of bringing a candle from the synagogue to a woman in labor suggests a belief that sacred objects from holy spaces carried special protective power. This reflects the common belief that objects associated with public prayer carried heightened spiritual efficacy.

[ii] The Talmud (Shabbat 31b-32a) identifies these three transgressions as negligence in observing niddah (menstrual purity laws), challah (separating dough offering), and hadlakat ha-ner (candle lighting). The text will soon explain these in detail.

[iii] This refers to the story in the Jerusalem Talmud (Yevamot 12:6) where Rabbi Joshua's mother would bring his cradle to the study hall so that his ears would become accustomed to Torah from his earliest days. The Talmud praises her for this and attributes his wisdom to these early exposures.

היה לו חיים.[i] ולהשיג החיים העליונים צריכות להשמר בג׳ דברים שאותן עבירות גורמות דבקות החצונים אליהם והיא המיתה והקליפה הכרוכה במדתם שהמות היא נקבה נמשכת מס״מ.[ii] זהירות ראשון נדה להבדל מן החצונים שאם ח״ו יתקרבו אל הזכר הוא ע״רו״ה ולזה מיד מדת הדין תתעורר אליהן מלמעלה והמיתה כרוכה בעקבם. הב׳ אחר תקונן ורחקן מן החיצונים צריכות עוד זהירות חלה[iii] דהיינו סלוק המלכות שהיא חלה ראשית עריסותיכם העולה לידבק בימין ליחוד. ואחר זה צריכות עוד הדלקת הנר שהיא מדתן הנגזרת בסוד תקונה העליון בפתילה ושמן ועריכת נר כי הכלי ה״א והפתילה ו׳ והשמן י׳ והנר אש מצד ה׳ עליונה[iv] שממנה יצאו ה׳ אורות ולכן צריך לכוין בתקון

themselves in three matters, as those transgressions cause attachment of external forces to them, which is death and the shell (kelipah) that is bound up with their attribute—for death is female, extending from Samael.[1] 30R

The first precaution is regarding niddah (menstrual purity), to separate from the external forces, for if, God forbid, they approach the male, it constitutes nakedness. For this reason, the attribute of judgment immediately awakens toward them from above, and death is bound to their heels. The second, after their rectification and distancing from the external forces, they still need to be careful about challah, meaning the elevation of Malkhut, which is challah, "the first of your dough," ascending to adhere to the right for unification.[A] 35R 40R

After this, they still need candle-lighting, which is their attribute, ordained in the mystery of its supernal rectification with wick, oil, and the arrangement of the lamp—for the vessel is the letter hei, the wick is vav, the oil is yod, and the flame is fire from the aspect of the upper hei,[2] from which five lights emanate. Therefore, one must intend in preparing the 45R

[A] Or: "meaning the elevation of the divine attribute of Malkhut, symbolized by challah offering, "the first portion of your dough," which ascends to unite with the right side (Chesed) for divine unification" — This expanded translation more explicitly identifies Malkhut as a divine attribute and clarifies that the 'right' refers to Chesed (loving-kindness) in the kabbalistic system, making the mystical concept more accessible to readers without background in kabbalah.

(Malkhut, associated with David) receives its vitality from higher sefirot rather than having its own independent source of life.

[1] In kabbalistic literature, death is often personified as female and associated with Lilith or other female demonic entities connected to Samael (the angel of death). This reflects the gendered cosmology of medieval Jewish mysticism where feminine principles were often associated with judgment and limitation.

[2] The author maps the physical components of a lamp onto the four letters of the divine name YHVH (יהוה), transforming the mundane act of lighting candles into a cosmic ritual that symbolically unifies God's name. This exemplifies how kabbalistic thinking infused ordinary Jewish rituals with mystical significance.

[i] According to midrashic tradition, David was not originally allotted years of his own but received 70 years from Adam's original 1,000-year allocation. In Kabbalistic symbolism, David represents the sefirah of Malkhut, which has no light of its own but receives from the sefirot above it.

[ii] In kabbalistic symbolism, death is portrayed as feminine and associated with Samael (ס״מ), the angel of death. This gendered spiritual cosmology reflects medieval conceptions of masculine and feminine principles in the divine and demonic realms.

[iii] The author establishes a progressive spiritual process: first, a woman separates from impurity through niddah observance, then elevates spiritually through the challah offering. This creates a narrative of increasing spiritual refinement through the three commandments.

[iv] This represents a kabbalistic correspondence between the components of the lamp and the letters of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH): the vessel corresponds to the lower hei (ה), the wick to vav (ו), the oil to yod (י), and the flame to the upper hei (ה). This transforms candle-lighting into a ritual that symbolically unifies the divine name.

הנר לרחוץ ולקנח אותה יפה
50 דהיינו תקון מלכות ורחיצתה
מכל טנוף וזהו לשון הטבת
הנרות הנאמר במנורה[i] שבזה
מכינה לקבל חסד הנקרא אור כי
יהל עליה. ובג׳ מצות אלו החיים
55 העליונים שהם מחכמה בסוד
רוח החיים פנימיות הספירות
נמשכים למטה[ii]

lamp to wash and clean it well, meaning the rectification of Malkhut and its cleansing from all impurity. 50R
This is the meaning of "preparing the lamps" mentioned regarding the Menorah, for through this she prepares it to receive kindness, which is called light, so that it may shine upon her. Through these three commandments, the supernal life, which comes from 55R
Wisdom in the mystery of the breath of life within the inner aspects of the Sefirot, is drawn downward.[1]

ובשעת לידה א״א כי לא
יתנו חלק לנחש הנושך באותו
60 מקום[iii] דהיינו טומאת לידה
והדם והצירים כלם חלק
לחצונים והנולד בלא חבלי
לידה כ״כ סי׳ יפה לו. ואם
המדה הזאת אינה מתוקנת
65 כראוי להציל לה מאלו החצונים
הנכרכים בעקבה[iv] ח״ו. מיד

And at the time of childbirth, it is impossible that they would not give a portion to the biting serpent in that place, namely the impurity of childbirth, the 60R
blood, and the labor pains—all of which are a share for the external forces.[2] One who is born without such intense birth pangs has a good sign.[3] And if this attribute [of the woman] is not properly rectified to save her from these external forces that coil around 65R
her heel, God forbid, they will immediately ascend

[1]This concluding statement emphasizes that proper observance of these three commandments creates a channel for divine life force to flow from the highest spiritual realms (Wisdom/Chokhmah) down to the physical world. This exemplifies the kabbalistic principle that human ritual actions affect cosmic processes.

[2]"External forces" (chitzonim) is a kabbalistic term for negative spiritual entities that derive sustenance from impurity. This passage describes childbirth as necessarily involving some spiritual impurity that feeds these forces.

[3]This suggests that easier births indicate less spiritual impurity and thus less sustenance provided to negative forces, considered a positive spiritual indication.

[i]The author draws a direct parallel between a woman's domestic candle-lighting and the priestly service of preparing the Temple Menorah, elevating this household ritual to the status of Temple service. This reflects the post-Temple Jewish approach of transforming the home into a 'small sanctuary.'

[ii]Cf. Zohar — The author cites the Zohar as an authoritative source regarding women's obligation to pray for their families during candle-lighting, establishing a connection between ritual practice and spiritual protection. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud — The author draws directly on this talmudic source that establishes these three mitzvot as particularly essential for women, with severe consequences for negligence. Ma'avar Yabok expands this with kabbalistic interpretations of why these particular commandments are spiritually significant for women. | Cf. Story of Rabbi Joshua ben Hananiah — The author uses this reference to emphasize the sensitivity and awareness of the unborn child, suggesting that a pregnant woman's actions and environments have direct spiritual impact on her child's development. | Cf. David having no life of his own — The author uses this reference to illustrate the kabbalistic concept that women, associated with the sefirah of Malkhut (which is symbolized by David), have a derivative spiritual vitality that requires connection to higher sources through proper observance of mitzvot. | Cf. Candle preparation of the Menorah — The author draws a parallel between a woman's preparation of Sabbath candles and the priestly service in the Temple, elevating the domestic ritual to the level of sacred service with cosmic significance. This suggests women should approach candle lighting with similar intention and devotion as the priests in their service.

[iii]The "biting serpent" is a kabbalistic reference to demonic forces that derive sustenance from childbirth impurity. The imagery draws on the curse to the serpent in Genesis 3:15 about striking at the heel.

[iv]"External forces that coil around her heel" refers to kabbalistic concept of negative spiritual entities (chitzonim) that attach themselves to humans, particularly at vulnerable moments. The heel imagery alludes to Genesis 3:15 where the serpent strikes at humanity's heel.

יסתלקו למעלה ויאחזו בה.
ובתקון י״ז דף כ״ו ע״א אמרו
כי חטה סוד כ״ב אותיות התורה
70 היה האילן שאכל אדה״ר[i] ולא
הוציא ממנו חלה. ע״כ לא חל בו
ה׳ רק א׳ שהוא חטא[ii] וגרם לו
מיתה. וחלה היא שכינה כלולה
מז׳ מינים וצריך להפריש
75 מהעיסה חלה ומיד חל ה׳ על
ההיא טפה ונותן לו זרע בולל
לזכר ולנקבה בסוד הא לכם
זרע ונצטווה מצוה זו לאשה
שהמיתה חלתו של עולם[iii] לכן
80 צריכה להפריש חלה מעיסתה
שהיא טפה שלה להחזירה על
אדם וצריכה להדליק נר של
שבת בהתעוררות להבות אש
אהבה לגבי בעלה כי התעורות
85 החמימות בליל שבת מאשתו
צריך שתהיה באהבה וזהו אשה
כי תזריע וילדה זכר על שפיכות
דמים של אדם הראשון נזרקת
דמה ע״כ צריכה לשמור אותו

and take hold of her.

In Tikkun 17, page 26a, they said that wheat, which contains the secret of the 22 letters of the Torah, was the tree from which Adam ate,[A] but 70R
he did not separate challah from it.[1] Therefore, the letter Hei did not rest in it, only Alef, which represents sin, and this caused him death.[B] Challah is the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), which includes the seven species,[2] and one must separate 75R
challah from the dough. Then the letter Hei immediately rests upon that drop and gives it seed encompassing both male and female, in the secret of "behold, to you is seed." This commandment was given to women because death became the world's por- 80R
tion (challah).[3] Therefore, she must separate challah from her dough, which is her seed, to restore it to humanity.

A woman must also kindle the Sabbath light with an awakening of flames of love toward her husband, 85R
for the arousal of warmth on Sabbath night from his wife should be with love. This is the meaning of "when a woman conceives and bears a male child." For the bloodshed of Adam, her blood is cast

[A] Or: "wheat—which holds the mystery of the 22 letters of the Torah—was the tree from which the first man ate" — This alternate translation more explicitly renders 'אדה״ר' as 'the first man' rather than just 'Adam' and treats the mystical connection to letters as a 'mystery' rather than a 'secret,' which might better convey the kabbalistic nature of the teaching.

[B] Or: "As a result, the letter Hei did not dwell within it, only Alef, which transforms it into 'sin' (chet), and this brought death upon him" — This alternate more explicitly shows the wordplay in Hebrew between חטה (wheat) and חטא (sin) when the letter ה (Hei) is replaced with א (Alef). It also uses 'dwell' instead of 'rest' which might better convey the kabbalistic concept of divine letters inhabiting or indwelling within reality.

[1] Challah separation is the ritual removal of a portion of dough before baking bread, which is consecrated to God (originally given to priests). The text reinterprets Adam's sin as failing to perform this separation, which would have elevated the physical to the spiritual realm.

[2] This identifies the separated portion of dough (challah) with the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) and connects it to the seven species mentioned in Deuteronomy 8:8 (wheat, barley, grapes, figs, pomegranates, olives, and dates) that were special to the Land of Israel.

[3] This passage contains wordplay between 'challah' (דough offering) and 'portion' that's difficult to convey in translation. It suggests women have special responsibility for challah separation as cosmic rectification for Eve's role in bringing death into the world.

[i] This presents an alternative kabbalistic tradition about the forbidden tree in Eden being wheat rather than the more commonly assumed apple or fig. This interpretation is found in various midrashic and kabbalistic texts.

[ii] This passage plays on the Hebrew words חטה (chitah/wheat) and חטא (chet/sin), suggesting that when the letter ה (hei, associated with the Divine Presence) is replaced with א (alef), wheat (sustenance) becomes sin (spiritual corruption).

[iii] This creates a wordplay between חלה (challah/dough offering) and חלה (chalah/portion), suggesting that because Eve brought death as the world's "portion," women must separate challah as rectification.

מדם נדה. ואמרו בתקון כ״ד כי נר שבת תהיה לימין ותחשב לאשה כאלו תקנה מנורה בדרום ששה חכמה והשלחן בצפון בינה[i] מטה בין צפון לדרום בסוד החבוק הכנה לזווג ושלחן היא שכינה הבאה מן הצפון וצריך לתקן אותה לבעלה כי שבת דמעלי שבתא הוא תקוני דמטרוניתא שכינה ות״ת יורדים אליה. וג״פ מקדש השבת שהם בערבית עם הקידוש על הכוס הם במלכות וג״פ מקדש השבת שהם בשחרית עם המפטיר יהיה סוד קדושת שבת בבינה ששם עולים מלכות ות״ת וב׳ פעמים שבמוסף יהיה הקדושה מכח הכתר ע״י יסוד המוסיף קדושה על קדושה[ii] וזה סוד תפלת מוסף בכל מקום וב״פ במנחה יהיה סוד הקדושה בת״ת שעולה שם מלכות ויורדת שם בינה.[iii]

forth;[1] therefore, she must guard it from the blood of menstrual impurity.

And they said in Tikkun 24 that the Sabbath lamp should be placed on the right, and it is considered for a woman as if she prepared the Menorah in the south, which is Wisdom, and the table in the north, which is Understanding. The bed is between north and south, in the secret of the embrace, a preparation for union.[2] The table is the Shekhinah, coming from the north, and one must prepare her for her husband, for the Sabbath of Sabbath eve is the rectification of the Matronita (Divine Feminine).[A] The Shekhinah and Tiferet descend to her.

The three recitations of "Who sanctifies the Sabbath" that are in the evening service, along with the Kiddush over the cup, are in Malkhut. The three recitations in the morning service, along with the Maftir, contain the secret of Sabbath sanctification in Binah, where Malkhut and Tiferet ascend. The two recitations in the Musaf service derive their sanctity from the power of Keter through Yesod, which

[A] Or: "the adornment of the Matronita (the Queen, Divine Feminine)" — The term 'תקוני' in kabbalistic contexts often refers to 'adornment' or 'preparation' of the Divine Feminine, especially in Sabbath contexts, where the Shekhinah is adorned like a bride. This alternative better captures the bridal imagery implicit in the kabbalistic concept.

[1] This connects menstrual blood to Adam's sin, suggesting women's monthly cycles are a form of atonement for the primordial sin. This reflects the text's integration of physical processes into a cosmic spiritual framework.

[2] The Hebrew term for 'union' here has strong mystical connotations, referring to the sexual union that mirrors divine unification of masculine and feminine attributes. The arrangement of household items is seen as creating the proper cosmic conditions for both human and divine unions.

[i] This references the Temple arrangement where the Menorah stood in the south (associated with Chokhmah/Wisdom) and the Table of Showbread in the north (associated with Binah/Understanding), establishing the home as a microcosmic Temple.

[ii] This passage refers to the kabbalistic concept that the Musaf (additional) prayer service draws down additional sanctity from Keter (Crown), the highest divine emanation, through Yesod (Foundation), which channels divine flow.

[iii] Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This citation connects the ritual of challah separation to the rectification of Adam's sin. By not separating challah, Adam failed to elevate the physical (wheat) to the spiritual realm, leading to the separation of the divine letter Hei (representing the Divine Presence) and causing death to enter the world. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This reference establishes a cosmic map where ritual objects in the home (lamp, table, bed) correspond to specific divine attributes (Wisdom/Chokhmah, Understanding/Binah) and cosmic directions, showing how proper household arrangement creates a microcosm of divine harmony that facilitates both human and divine union. | Cf. Leviticus 12:2 — The text uses this biblical reference to connect women's physical processes (menstruation, childbirth) to cosmic rectification. It suggests that proper observance of family purity laws counteracts the bloodshed associated with Adam's sin and creates spiritual protection for women. | Cf. Genesis 1:29 — The text reads this phrase from Genesis about God giving seed-bearing plants as food in kabbalistic terms of spiritual generativity. The separation of challah is seen as activating divine feminine energy (the letter Hei) which enables proper spiritual

adds sanctity upon sanctity[1]—this is the secret of the Musaf prayer in every instance. And the two recitations in the Mincha service contain the secret of sanctity in Tiferet, where Malkhut ascends and Binah descends. 115R

ואמר הסבא דף קי״ט שהנשים שאינן שומרות מצות וטהרתן בדקא יאות או שמקדימות לטבול[i] כי עון הנחש אוחז בהן ובקולן בכל בכלבתא[ii] שהולך אחר הטומאה מין אחר מינו וממית הרבה פעמים התינוקות הנולדים מהן רחמנא ליצלן לבן כל בת ישראל תשמור פתחי טהרתה בראוי וכל היד המרבה לבדוק בנשים משובחת[iii] וכמה פעמים צווחתי על אותן המקדימות לטבול בעוד היום גדול כי אינה מבילה

The Saba says on page 119 that women who do not properly observe the commandments and ritual purity, or who immerse prematurely,[2] are affected by the serpent's sin which grips them and their voices like a female dog[A] that follows impurity after its kind.[3] This often causes the death of children born to them—may the Merciful One protect us. Therefore, every daughter of Israel should properly guard the gates of her purity, and any woman who frequently examines herself is praiseworthy.[B] I have repeatedly protested against those who immerse while it is still daytime, for this is not immersion at its proper time on the seventh day, and from then onward there is concern about her daughter following suit.[4] One 120R 125R 130R

[A] Or: "the sin of the primordial serpent takes hold of them and their voices like a female dog in heat" — The phrase might be referring more specifically to a female dog in heat, which would align with the text's concern about sexuality and purity. This translation captures the more explicit sexual connotation that may be present in the original.

[B] Or: "the more frequently a woman examines herself [for ritual purity], the more praiseworthy she is" — This alternative more clearly conveys the underlying rabbinic principle being adapted here—that increasing vigilance in checking for ritual purity is considered meritorious, similar to the Passover directive about searching for leaven.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the Musaf (additional) service brings an additional level of sanctity beyond the regular prayers, mirroring how Yesod (Foundation) channels additional divine flow from higher sefirot to lower ones.

[2] The text is addressing the Jewish laws of niddah (menstrual purity), which require women to immerse in a mikveh (ritual bath) seven days after their menstruation ends. The author is criticizing women who don't follow these laws precisely or who immerse before nightfall on the seventh day.

[3] This harsh metaphor reflects medieval attitudes about ritual impurity. The comparison to a dog draws on negative symbolism in Jewish tradition where dogs were often considered impure animals.

[4] The Hebrew phrase 'serach bitah' refers to the concern that a daughter will learn improper practices from her mother, perpetuating ritual errors across generations.

generation and union of masculine and feminine principles. | Cf. Zohar — This parallel draws on classic Zoharic teachings about how the different prayer services of Shabbat create a progressive spiritual ascent through the sefirot. The passage shows how prayers create pathways for the Shekhinah (Malkhut) to ascend and unite with higher divine attributes throughout the Sabbath day.

[i] The author refers to the Saba (the Elder), which is a reference to a section of the Zohar known as Saba d'Mishpatim. This text is emphasizing the importance of women's ritual purity laws, particularly regarding the timing of immersion in the mikveh (ritual bath) after menstruation.

[ii] This is a kabbalistic reference to the primordial sin of the serpent (nachash) in the Garden of Eden. The text uses the metaphor of a female dog (kalbeta in Aramaic) to describe how this ancient sin attaches to women who don't properly observe purification rituals.

[iii] This phrase refers to the practice of women examining themselves for signs of menstrual blood to determine their ritual status. The Hebrew uses a play on a Talmudic saying about Passover examination (kol hayad hamarbeh livdok et hechametz meshubachat).

בזמנה ביום שביעי ומשם והלאה
איכא משום סרך בתה. כי
צריך לעולם להמתין עד הערב
בדליכא אונס ניכר. ואמר
הסבא כי על עון זה מתאבדי
בני עלמא בלא דעתא[i] ווי
לנשי בישא דגרמין דא להון
ולבעליהון ולבניהון. והרבה
דברים תלויים בעליית האשה
מבית טבילתה כפי מה שתפגע
בה כן יהיו בניה ככתוב בספרי
החכמים ומשום הכי רבי יוחנן
הוה יתיב אשערי טבילה[ii] ומעשה
באלישע כהן גדול שלא היו בניו
מקויימין מפני שלא היתה אשתו
נזהרת במי שפוגעת בצאתה
מהטבילה עד שפגע בה מטטרון
שר הפנים.[iii] ושמשה עם בעלה
בשמחה ונתעברה מרבי ישמעאל
כהן גדול והיה דיוקנו דומה לו.
וכשמקדמת לטבול יש יותר חשש
שתפגע בדברים שאינם מהוגנים
כי לכל זמן ועת לכל חפץ
תחת השמים. ומי שפוגע באשה
דסלקא מבית הטבילה לימא
הכי שופך בוז על נדיבים ויתעם
בתוהו לא דרך. ובטן אשה רעה
נמסר לס״מ ובזה נדחה מבטן

must always wait until evening when there is no obvious necessity otherwise.

The Saba says that because of this sin, people perish without understanding. Woe to the wicked women who cause this harm to themselves, their husbands, and their children. Many things depend on what a woman encounters when ascending from the ritual bath—as she encounters, so will her children be, as written in the books of the sages. This is why Rabbi Yochanan would sit at the gates of the ritual bath.[1] There was an incident involving Elisha the High Priest whose children did not survive because his wife was not careful about whom she encountered when leaving the ritual bath, until she encountered Metatron, the Prince of the Divine Presence.[2] She then had marital relations with her husband in joy and conceived Rabbi Ishmael the High Priest, whose appearance resembled him [Metatron].[3] When a woman immerses early, there is greater concern that she will encounter improper things, for "there is a time and season for everything under heaven."

One who encounters a woman ascending from the ritual bath should say: "He pours contempt upon nobles and makes them wander in pathless wastes." The womb of an evil woman is delivered to Samael,[4] and through this he is driven away from the womb of a good woman. Because they stole from

[1] This anecdote about Rabbi Yochanan doesn't appear in the Talmud but is found in kabbalistic literature. It demonstrates a belief that the environment and encounters immediately after ritual immersion were spiritually significant.

[2] In Jewish mysticism, encountering angels could have profound spiritual effects. This story suggests that meeting Metatron—one of the highest angels—immediately after ritual immersion resulted in the conception of a child with special spiritual qualities.

[3] The text suggests that Rabbi Ishmael the High Priest physically resembled the angel Metatron, implying that an encounter with angels could influence the physical characteristics of children conceived afterward.

[4] In Jewish mysticism, Samael is often identified as the angel of death or the chief of evil spirits. This passage suggests that women who don't observe purity laws properly place their reproductive capacity under the influence of negative spiritual forces.

[i] The phrase 'mitabdei bnei alma belo da'ata' is Aramaic, referring to people perishing without understanding or awareness of the spiritual consequences of their actions.

[ii] This refers to a rabbinic story about Rabbi Yochanan sitting at the entrance to the ritual bath. The story demonstrates the importance ancient sages placed on the encounters women had immediately after immersion, believing these encounters could influence the nature of children conceived afterwards.

[iii] Metatron is one of the highest angels in Jewish mysticism, sometimes described as the 'Prince of the Divine Presence' (Sar HaPanim). The text suggests a mystical encounter between Elisha the High Priest's wife and this angel, resulting in the birth of Rabbi Ishmael who resembled the angel.

אשה טובה[i] בגרמא דא ובגין
155 דבלבושין דיליה גזילו מיניה
כל ברכאן עילא אשכחו רתיכין
דיליה לרבנן במאניהון דבלו
מחופייא דידהו ובגין דגזלו
מיניה ירך דאשה טובה בג״ד
160 הני ברכי דשלהי מינייהו הוי
ולית מלה בלא דינא וכל מלה
תב לאתריה וכל דינין דקב״ה
דינין דקשוט אינון.[ii] ותנוקות
אלו שאמרנו מורידים דמעות
165 ואומרים מארי עלמא מה פשענו
בזה ועוד תנוק בן יומו דחב
עבדין ביה דינא[iii] וקב״ה
קרי להון בן דכתיב אני היום
ילידתיך.[iv] ואינון עם אותם
170 דמסתלקי מעלמא באובי
אבוהון דמעה דלהון מגינים על
החיים ויש להם מקום דאפילו
צדיקים גמורים אינם עולים
שם וקב״ה רחים לון ומתדבק
175 בהון ואתקן בהו מתיבתא
עלאה דיליה ועליהם כתיב
מפי עוללים ויונקים יסדת עז
למען צורריך[v] ובזה משביתים

him in his garments all the blessings above,[1] his
chariots found the sages in their worn garments from 160R
their coverings, and because they stole from him the
thigh of a good woman, these knees that weaken
come from them. Nothing is without judgment,
and everything returns to its place, and all the
judgments of the Holy One, blessed be He, are 165R
judgments of truth.

These children we mentioned shed tears and say,
“Master of the Universe, how have we sinned in
this?”[2] Moreover, even for a day-old child who has
sinned, they execute judgment,[A] and the Holy One, 170R
blessed be He, calls them “son,” as it is written,
“Today I have begotten you.” They, along with
those who depart from the world in their fathers’
iniquity—their tears protect the living. They have
a place where even the completely righteous do 175R
not ascend,[3] and the Holy One, blessed be He,
loves them and cleaves to them, and establishes
His supernal academy with them. Concerning
them it is written, “From the mouths of babes and
sucklings You have established strength because of 180R
Your adversaries,” and through this they silence the
enemy and avenger.

Since in a time of divine wrath even positive com-

[A] Or: “judgment is executed upon him” — This passive construction more accurately reflects the original Aramaic phrasing, which indicates that judgment happens to the infant rather than the infant executing judgment.

[1] This cryptic passage refers to complex kabbalistic ideas about how proper ritual observance by women ‘steals’ power from negative spiritual forces, thereby redirecting divine blessings from evil to good.

[2] This poignant passage imagines the souls of children who died in infancy questioning their fate. It reflects theological wrestling with the problem of innocent suffering.

[3] This represents the Jewish mystical belief that children who die young have a special elevated status in the spiritual realms, higher even than fully righteous adults. This concept offered comfort to parents who lost children.

[i] S”M is an abbreviation for Samael, the angel of death in Jewish mysticism. The passage uses kabbalistic imagery to explain how evil spiritual forces can affect women’s wombs, and how proper ritual observance pushes these forces away from righteous women.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase affirms that all divine judgments are true and just. ‘Dinim d’keshot’ means judgments of truth.

[iii] This references the complex theological question of why infants die, suggesting that even day-old infants may have sinned in some mystical sense. This reflects certain kabbalistic views about pre-existence of souls.

[iv] This is a quote from Psalms 2:7, “Today I have begotten you,” which the text applies to infants who die young, suggesting they have a special relationship with God.

[v] This quote from Psalms 8:3 (“From the mouths of babes and sucklings You have established strength because of Your adversaries”) is used to support the idea that deceased infants have a special spiritual power.

אויב ומתנקם. ולהיות כי בעידן
ריתחא מענשי אפילו אשתה[i] גם
בן לאיש היוצא למלחמה אין
לדבר בחטאתיו פן יופקד עליו
למצוא עונו לשנא ח״ו. וזה
כלל לכל עת סכנה שאין ללמוד
קטגוריא על שום איש ואשה:[ii]

mandments are punishable,[1] likewise for a person going to war, one should not speak of his sins lest they be counted against him to find his iniquity to hate him, God forbid. This is a general principle for any dangerous time: one should not teach accusation against any man or woman.

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

לו חכמו ישבילו זאת יבינו
לאחריתם. מבקרי חולה בחוליו
שבחי חי הוא יודה ויתחנן במו
פיו למלכו ואב לבנים יודיע
וירגיל אותו להעתיר אל אלוה
מילין בפסוקי דאנ״ך כי הנה
ה׳ נצב על חומת אנ״ך למשגב
לעתות בצרה.[iii] דלהגן שאני

If they were wise, they would understand this; they would discern their latter end.[A] Those who visit the sick in their illness should encourage the living one to praise and supplicate with his own mouth to his King, and a father should make known to his children and accustom him to entreat God with words from the verses of Scripture, for behold, the Lord stands upon the wall of Scripture[2] as

[A] Or: "If they were wise, they would comprehend this and understand their ultimate purpose" — This alternative captures the philosophical dimension of the verse, emphasizing that understanding one's mortality leads to deeper existential awareness rather than merely foreseeing future events.

[1] This refers to the Talmudic concept that during periods of strict divine judgment, even failing to perform positive commandments (not just violating prohibitions) can result in punishment. This concept was extended to dangerous situations like warfare.

[2] The author creates a powerful image combining the prophetic vision in Amos 7:7 (where God stands on a wall with a measuring line) with the idea of Scripture itself forming a protective wall around the ill person.

[i] This refers to the Talmudic concept that in times of divine anger or judgment, people may be punished even for failing to perform positive commandments (which normally don't carry punishment), not just for violating prohibitions.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Saba d'Mishpatim — The author is directly drawing on this mystical text to establish the spiritual importance of proper ritual immersion timing for women. The Zohar is the central text of Jewish mysticism, so this reference establishes the mystical framework for understanding women's purity practices. | Cf. Niddah laws in the Talmud — While not directly quoting specific Talmudic passages, the text is clearly engaging with and expanding upon Talmudic discussions about women's ritual purity. The author adds kabbalistic interpretations to these halakhic requirements, showing how ritual timing connects to cosmic spiritual forces. | Cf. Psalms 8:3 — The author reinterprets this psalm, which originally praised God for giving even children the ability to recognize divine greatness, to suggest that the souls of deceased infants have special spiritual power to silence accusers and provide protection for the living. | Cf. Psalms 2:7 — The psalm originally referred to God's relationship with the king of Israel, but here it's reinterpreted to suggest that God has a special parental relationship with infants who die young, claiming them as divine children. | Cf. Midrash on Elisha the High Priest — This narrative element connects to a broader Jewish mystical tradition about how encounters immediately after ritual immersion can influence conception. The specific story doesn't appear in canonical rabbinic literature in precisely this form, suggesting the author may be drawing on oral traditions or lesser-known mystical texts. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 3:1 — This biblical allusion reinforces the text's emphasis on proper timing for ritual immersion. By invoking Ecclesiastes, the author suggests that ritual timing is part of the divine cosmic order, not merely a technical religious requirement.

[iii] This is a wordplay on the acronym אנ״ך (Scripture: Torah, Prophets, and Writings) and Amos 7:7 where God stands on a wall with a plumb line (אנך). The author suggests that Scripture itself serves as a protective wall.

ומותר ושרי[i] וכל הקודם ומרבה
זריז ונשכר לשחר אל אל בכתבי
הנבואה הנאמרים ברוח עצה
וגבורה. ובזה תאציל לך ברכות
בחשבון מחשבתך. ובו תדבק
ותבאיש פני ההולכים בקרב
נגד גופך ונשמתך ובזה תזכה
לתוחלת התעלה והתשועה
ואלהיך ירצך ויאר פניו אליך
ויחונך וישם לך שלום והסיר
ממך כל חולי וכל מדוה וחשוב
לימי עלומיך. ע״כ היום יצאתי
להקריב לפניך אחי פסוקי
מנגדי נהרי דבש וחלב וחמאה
שלשים ושש לכל סדר[ii] מופקדים
ומונחים יחד בקצת מועצות
ודעת הצפון בתוכניותם.
הקרואים זה אל זה. למען בימי
דבאך בשפתיך תקדיש את קדוש
ישראל. ובפיך תכבד לאלהי
הכבוד בהם. ומהם תתענג על
מי מנוחות ונחלי עדן ובמלין
אלו אשר לצד עלאה תמלל הוא
יבריאך ויעצימך וביום השלישי
תעלה בית ה׳[iii] על כן הטוב
לך עמיתי כי תבחר ואקרב בהם
והיית מוצק ולא תירא ובצל שדי
תתלונן:[iv]

a stronghold in times of trouble. For to protect
oneself is different, permissible, and allowed, and
whoever comes first and increases [in these prayers]
is diligent and rewarded for seeking God through
the writings of prophecy spoken with the spirit of
counsel and might. Through this, you will draw
down blessings in accordance with your thoughts.
You will cling to Him and cause to stink the faces
of those who walk in your midst against your
body and soul, and through this you will merit
the hope of elevation and salvation. Your God
will favor you, make His face shine upon you, be
gracious to you, grant you peace, remove from you
all sickness and disease, and restore the days of
your youth. Therefore, today I have come forth
to offer before you, my brother, verses from the
rivers of honey, milk, and butter[A]—thirty-six for
each arrangement[1]—entrusted and placed together
with some counsel and knowledge hidden within
them, calling to one another. So that in the days
of your suffering, with your lips you may sanctify
the Holy One of Israel, and with your mouth honor
the God of glory through them. From them you
will delight upon the waters of rest and the streams
of Eden, and through these words which you will
utter toward the supernal side, He will heal you
and strengthen you, and on the third day you will
ascend to the house of the Lord.[2] Therefore, it is

10R 15R 20R 25R 30R 35R

[A] Or: "verses corresponding to flowing streams of honey, milk, and butter" — This alternative more directly captures the sense of 'מנגדי' as 'corresponding to' or 'aligned with' rather than simply 'from,' emphasizing the parallel between these scriptural verses and the metaphorical rivers of sustenance.

[1] The number 36 has mystical significance in Jewish tradition, often associated with the thirty-six righteous individuals (lamed vav tzadikim) who sustain the world. Here it likely refers to specific collections of verses arranged for healing purposes.

[2] This suggests both physical recovery (being well enough to visit the synagogue) and spiritual

[i] The author is explaining that while some actions might normally be prohibited, seeking protection through Scripture during illness is permitted and even encouraged.

[ii] The author is referencing the collection of verses he has compiled—36 in each category—which he compares to rivers of honey, milk, and butter, biblical metaphors for abundance and spiritual sustenance.

[iii] This echoes Hosea 6:2, 'After two days He will revive us; on the third day He will raise us up.' It suggests that proper use of these scriptural verses will lead to recovery by the third day, allowing one to go to the Temple/synagogue.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage builds on the earlier framework by providing practical guidance for those who visit the sick, encouraging them to guide patients in reciting healing biblical verses. | Cf. Zohar — The author draws on kabbalistic concepts about the power of sacred words to create spiritual protections and healing channels for the ill person through proper recitation of Scripture. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:29 — By opening with this verse, the author suggests that proper understanding of Scripture's healing power is a form of wisdom that leads to better outcomes in times of illness. | Cf. Amos 7:7 — The author cleverly repurposes this image to suggest that

good for you, my colleague, to choose and draw near through them, and you will be firmly established and not fear,[A] and in the shadow of the Almighty you will abide.

ירגיל המבקש רחמים מבעל החסדים לשונו לדבר צחות בששה פסוקים של תורה וי״ב של נביאים וי״ח של כתובים כי לעולם המקבל קטן מהכיל כל שפע המשפיע[i] עד כי יכין כנגדו ממטה למעלה פעמים פי שנים מרוחו ופעמים פחות מפי שנים. הצד השוה כי לעולם לא ישתוה כח המקבל נגד המשפיע ורוחניות פסוקי תורה הנאמרים באספקלריא המאירה[ii] מאד עצמו ראשיתם צריך י״ב פסוקי נביאים להלביש רוחניות המתפשט מהם אל תוכם שהן הם תרין נביאי קשוט[iii] המקבלים הארת הת״ת תורה שבכתב עליהם.[iv] ברם רוחניות פסוקי הנביאים מתלבשים ומאירים בפסוקים הנאמרים ברוח הקדש

One who seeks mercy from the Master of Compassion[1] should accustom their tongue to speak clearly through six verses from the Torah, twelve from the Prophets, and eighteen from the Writings. For the receiver is always smaller than what is needed to contain all the abundance of the giver, until they prepare themselves from below to above, sometimes with twice the spiritual power and sometimes with less than twice. The common denominator is that the power of the receiver will never equal that of the giver. The spirituality of Torah verses, which are spoken through the brightly illuminating lens,[2] are so potent at their source that they require twelve verses from the Prophets to clothe the spirituality that extends from them, for these are the two prophets of truth who receive the illumination of Tiferet, the Written Torah,[3] upon themselves. However, the spirituality of the prophetic verses becomes clothed and illuminated in verses spoken through the Holy Spirit, with a third part more

[A] Or: "and you will be strong as cast metal and not fear" — The term 'מוצק' can refer to metal that has been cast or poured, suggesting a transformation from liquid to solid state. This alternative captures the metallurgical metaphor that might be intended, implying a transformation from weakness to strength.

elevation. The 'third day' motif appears throughout biblical literature as a time of transformation and deliverance.

[1] The Hebrew term 'baal ha-chasadim' literally means 'master of kindnesses' and refers to God as the source of all compassionate acts.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic concept of 'aspaklaria ha-me'irah,' the clear prophetic vision attributed to Moses, contrasted with the 'dim lens' through which other prophets perceived divine truth.

[3] In kabbalistic thought, the sefirah of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) is associated with the Written Torah, while Malkhut is associated with the Oral Torah.

Scripture itself (אנ״ך/TaNaKh) forms a protective wall around the ill, with God standing upon it as defender. | Cf. Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26) — The author incorporates elements of this blessing to suggest that proper use of scriptural verses during illness invokes the same divine protection and favor as the priestly blessing.

[i] This expresses the kabbalistic concept that the receiver (human soul or lower spiritual entity) has limited capacity compared to the divine abundance that flows from above.

[ii] The term "illuminating lens" (aspaklaria ha-me'irah) refers to the highest level of prophetic vision, traditionally attributed to Moses, who saw through a clear lens as opposed to other prophets who saw through a dim lens.

[iii] "Two prophets of truth" is an Aramaic phrase that typically refers to Moses and Aaron or, in kabbalistic thought, to the sefirot of Netzach and Hod, which channel prophetic influx.

[iv] This refers to the kabbalistic understanding that the Written Torah emanates from the sefirah of Tiferet (abbreviated as ת״ת), which represents harmony and truth in the divine emanation system.

בשליש עודף עליהם והרמז וכל
בשליש עפר הארץ שהיא מלכות.
ומשם בסוד ההשתלשלות של
שרף וחיה ואופן[i] יתלבשו שפע
הארות אלו בנפש רוח נשמה
של המתפלל והמתעורר דרך
המדרגות והצינורות המיוחדות
בסוד אם ימלאו העבים גשם
על הארץ יריקו. ובגשם
נדבות זה תניף אלהים שהם
בחות הדין מעל החולה וכלה
גרש יגרשו מעליו בחות ס״מ
ולילית[ii] הנקראים רעה ונגע
המתאבקים בו לסבת חטאתו
ועל פיהם יהיה כל ריב וכל
נגע וכל מחלה ומדוה שבגוף
האדם ובהבל פיו ימתיק הלהב
מהאש הקודח עליו כי קול
ה׳ חוצב להבות אש ומשקיען
בנוקבא דתהומא רבא.[iii] ועל
הרוב סבת היסורין יהיו או
מאש המקדיח או מקרח המגליד
השפע ומעכבו לסבת חשך ופגם
העונות המחשיכים ככבי נשפו
ואז החולה עומד בדין עליון
על מעשיו. ובתפלה ותשובה
מאיר החשך ומתקן הפגם ובסור
הסבה יסור המסובב וישלח ה׳
דברו והנהגתו מכח הרחמים
וירפאהו וימלט אותו משחיתותם
של נואף ונואפת דאינון עו״נ
בשב״ט עבר״תו[iv] שהבוק יבוק

than them, as hinted in the verse "and He measured the dust of the earth by the third part," which is Malkhut. And from there, through the mystery of the chain of emanation of Seraph, Chayah, and Ofan,[1] these illuminating flows will be clothed in 65R
the Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah[2] of the one who prays and awakens through the special levels and channels, in the secret of "if the clouds are full of rain, they empty themselves upon the earth." And through this shower of generosity, you will cause 70R
God—these being the forces of judgment—to be lifted from the sick person, and the forces of Samael and Lilith,[3] called "evil" and "plague," which cling to him because of his sin, will be completely driven away. It is by their word that every dispute, plague, 75R
disease, and malady in the human body comes about. And through the breath of his mouth, he will sweeten the flame of the fire burning upon him, for "the voice of the Lord hews out flames of fire" and sinks them into the opening of the great 80R
abyss.[4] Most often, the cause of suffering will be either from a kindling fire or from ice that freezes the divine flow and impedes it, due to the darkness and blemish of sins that darken like stars at dusk. Then the sick person stands in higher judgment 85R
for his deeds. But through prayer and repentance, the darkness is illuminated and the blemish is repaired, and when the cause is removed, its effect will depart. Then the Lord will send His word and guidance through the power of mercy, healing 90R
him and delivering him from the destruction of the adulterer and adulteress, which are "iniquity" and

[1] These are three categories of angels in Jewish mysticism, arranged hierarchically. They represent different levels through which divine energy descends from higher to lower realms.
[2] These are the three primary levels of the soul in Jewish mysticism, with Nefesh being the most basic (animating) level, Ruach the emotional/moral level, and Neshamah the intellectual/divine level.
[3] In Jewish demonology, particularly in kabbalistic texts, Samael and Lilith are considered the primary demonic couple. They are believed to cause illness, impurity, and spiritual harm.
[4] This refers to a cosmic location where negative spiritual forces are contained. The concept appears in kabbalistic texts describing how divine power neutralizes harmful entities.

[i] This references the kabbalistic concept of spiritual "chain of being" (hishtalshelut) and the three types of angels (Seraphim, Chayot, and Ofanim) that mediate divine energy through the spiritual worlds.
[ii] S"M is an abbreviation for Samael, the angel of death in Jewish mysticism. Together with Lilith, they represent the primary demonic couple in kabbalistic demonology, believed to cause illness and spiritual impurity.
[iii] An Aramaic phrase meaning "in the opening of the great abyss," referring to the mystical concept of a cosmic void or deep pit where negative forces are contained or neutralized.
[iv] These are coded references to negative spiritual forces. The acronyms likely represent biblical

כחו וכחה[i] בשפת אמת זו תורה
אשר לעד תכון. ובפסוקים אלו
פותחים שערי רחמים יחד כלם
הם במספר שלשים וששה לכל
פעם[ii] נגד שלשה מקורי מדות
הרחמים בתלו גלגל לב ובעולם
שנה נפש[iii] הממשיכים מקור
החיים מהחכמה סתימא עילאה
ומחכמה תתאה.[iv] לכן הם ב׳
פעמים ח״י כי חי הוא יודך
ויברכך ומשם יתעורר ארוכה
ומרפא מאריך[v] ברצון העליון
המושפע מבעל הרצון המעולה
על כל ברכה ותהלה. תהלת
ה׳ ידבר פי ויברך כל בשר שם
קדשו לעולם ועד:[vi]

"the rod of His wrath," whose power and strength will be utterly emptied[1] through the language of truth, which is Torah that stands forever. And through these verses, the gates of mercy are opened. Together they number thirty-six[2] for each time, corresponding to the three sources of the attributes of mercy in the heart-sphere-cycle and in the world-year-soul,[3] which draw the source of life from the supernal hidden Wisdom and from the lower Wisdom.[4] Therefore, they are twice eighteen, for "the living, the living shall praise You and bless You," and from there, healing and recovery will be awakened from the Elongated One[5] through the supernal will, which flows from the Master of the exalted will, beyond all blessing and praise. "May my mouth speak the praise of the Lord, and let all flesh bless His holy name forever and ever.""

[1]The original contains a wordplay on the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok,' suggesting that the negative forces will be 'emptied out' (yabbok from the root b-k-k) through proper spiritual practice.
[2]This number has significant mystical meaning in Judaism. It represents twice 18 (chai, meaning 'life') and is associated with the 36 righteous individuals who sustain the world in each generation.
[3]This refers to the kabbalistic concept of three interconnected dimensions: space (olam), time (shanah), and soul (nefesh), which form a matrix of divine manifestation in creation.
[4]In Kabbalah, these represent different aspects of Chokhmah (Wisdom): the higher, concealed aspect that is barely perceptible even to mystics, and the lower aspect that can be accessed through spiritual practice.
[5]This translates 'ma'arich,' which contains a wordplay on 'Arich Anpin' (the Long Face), a kabbalistic term for one of the highest divine configurations, associated with infinite mercy and patience.

phrases related to punishment and divine wrath.
[i]This is a wordplay on the book's title "Ma'avar Yabok" (the Crossing of the Yabok). The author suggests that the power of these negative forces will be "emptied out" (yabbok from the root b-k-k meaning "to empty") through proper spiritual practice.
[ii]The number 36 has mystical significance in Judaism, representing twice 18 (the numerical value of chai, "life"). It is associated with the 36 righteous individuals (lamed-vavniks) who sustain the world in each generation.
[iii]This references the kabbalistic concept of three interconnected dimensions: space (olam), time (shanah), and soul (nefesh), which correspond to different aspects of divine manifestation.
[iv]These Aramaic terms refer to the "Upper Hidden Wisdom" and "Lower Wisdom" in kabbalistic thought, representing different aspects of the divine intellect as manifested in the sefirah of Chokhmah at different levels.
[v]This contains a wordplay on the kabbalistic term "Arich" (the Long/Extended One), which refers to Arich Anpin, one of the divine countenances in Lurianic Kabbalah associated with the highest levels of divine mercy.
[vi]Cf. Zohar — The author draws on Zoharic concepts of the spiritual power of biblical verses and their hierarchical arrangement, where Torah verses have the highest potency, followed by Prophetic texts and then Writings. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 1:7 — The passage alludes to this concept when discussing how the receiver cannot fully contain the giver's abundance, similar to how the rivers continually flow into the sea without filling it. | Cf. Isaiah 40:12 — The text references this verse when mentioning 'the third part' of earth's dust, using it to illustrate the concept of divine measurement and proportion in spiritual influence. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 11:3 — The author directly quotes this verse to illustrate how divine abundance flows downward through spiritual channels, just as rain falls from clouds when they are full. | Cf. Psalm 29:7 — This quote is used to explain how prayer (the human voice directed toward God) has the power to transform and redirect the negative 'flames' affecting the sick person. | Cf. Isaiah 38:19 — The text alludes to this verse from Hezekiah's thanksgiving after healing, reinforcing the connection between life, healing, and praise

פרק ז׳

Chapter 7

ובו שמונה סדרים[i]

And it contains eight orders[1]

תומת ישרים תנחם בהוד והדר להגיד לאדם ישרו. ולמען יוכלו להתענג מזיו כבוד דברי מאמרי אלה. ולרבוץ בהליכותיהם בנהרי נחלי דבש וחמאה ויהיה שיח להם ושיג בדברים העקריים הראויים להיות לפני עדת ישרים ה״ה בני חבורת גומלי חסדים כהני חשיבי דשלוחי דרחמנא נינהו למזכרת. רוחי תניחם בהגותי לפניהם ברוח ולשון צח שפיים. ובכתיבה תמה בנקודותיה וטעמיה כדי להפיק רצונם. ולא יהיו עיניהם משוטטות אנה ואנה ובזה תהיה דרכם ישר לנגד עינם צדיקים יבואו בו ומעמל נפשם ישבעו שובע שמחות לאורך ימים כי יצמיחו ישועה לנפש שוקקה וידרשנה אלוה ממעל ותופע עליה נהורא. ונפש רעבה ימלאו טוב ויהיה אלהיו עמו ויעל ועל כן נחת שלחנם ימלא דשן בצוף דבש אמריהם כי נעמו וישבנו ארץ וירעו אמונה באהבה ואחוה באורך ימים. ובשני העולמות ה׳ אלהיהם ירצם ויושיעם כי חסו בו. שיתו נא לבבכם לאשר

The integrity of the upright guides them in glory and splendor to reveal to humanity their righteousness. So that they may delight in the radiant glory of these words of my discourse, and recline in their pathways among rivers and streams of honey and butter, and have conversation and discourse on essential matters worthy to be before the congregation of the upright—namely, the members of the charitable society, the esteemed priests who are emissaries of the Merciful One—as a remembrance. My spirit will give them rest as I meditate before them with a clear and refined spirit and language, and with perfect writing including its vowel points and cantillation marks, in order to fulfill their desire. Their eyes will not wander here and there, and thus their path will be straight before their eyes. The righteous will enter it and from the labor of their souls they will be satisfied[2] with abundant joy for length of days, for they will bring forth salvation to the yearning soul, and the Most High God will seek it out and light will shine upon it. The hungry soul they will fill with goodness, and his God will be with him and he will ascend. Therefore, the satisfaction of their table will be filled with abundance in the sweetness of honey, for their words are pleasant, and they will dwell in the land and feed on faithfulness with love and brotherhood for length of days. And in both worlds,[3] the Lord their God will favor them and save them, for

[1] The term ‘seder’ (plural ‘sedarim’) in this context refers to a structured arrangement of prayers, psalms, and biblical verses organized for specific ritual purposes. These eight orders provide different liturgical sequences for healing the sick, comforting the dying, and guiding those attending to them. Each ‘seder’ represents a complete liturgical unit appropriate for different situations or stages of illness.

[2] This refers to the spiritual rewards that those who perform the sacred duty of caring for the dying and deceased will receive. The author consistently emphasizes throughout Ma’avar Yabok that those who properly perform these rituals earn divine merit and protection.

[3] The Hebrew phrase ‘בשני העולמות’ (in both worlds) refers to this world (olam hazeh) and the World to Come (olam haba), reflecting the Jewish belief in rewards both in this life and after death. This dual focus is central to Ma’avar Yabok’s approach to end-of-life care.

of God, which is central to Ma’avar Yabok’s approach to illness. | Cf. Psalm 145:21 — The passage concludes with this verse, emphasizing the universal praise of God that results from healing and divine mercy, connecting personal healing to cosmic harmony.

[i] This short line is a subheading that introduces the ‘Seder’ section of Ma’avar Yabok, which contains eight distinct liturgical sequences or ‘orders’ of prayers, psalms, and verses to be recited for the sick and dying. The term ‘seder’ (order/arrangement) indicates a structured compilation of liturgical elements arranged for specific ritual purposes.

העבד הנאמן מציב לפניכם ומעפר אמרתו תצפצף לאלופיו המסובלים המאירים לארץ ולדרים. וה׳ ישפות עליכם שלום. ושלמא עלייכו: [i]

they have taken refuge in Him. Turn your hearts now to what the faithful servant sets before you, and from the dust his word will chirp[1] to his burdened chiefs who illuminate the earth and its inhabitants. And the Lord will grant you peace. And peace be upon you.

אמרו במדרש תהלים אדם חולה יום א׳ [ii] אז מה עושה צריך תפלה וכן ביום שני וביום ג׳ ביום רביעי מה הוא עושה אומר דוה הוא אמר הקב״ה עכשיו אני סועדו ומעמידו כל משכבו הפכת בחליו [iii] כל מה שהיה חוטא כל הימים שהיה עומד על רגליו הקב״ה הופך עליו חוליו א״כ מאן דשיים אורחוי סגי שוי ויראה בישע אלהים. ואמרו בסנהדרין כל המאמין עצמו בתפלה מלמטה אין לו צרים מלמעלה שנאמר היערוך שועך לא בצר והיה שדי בצריך [iv] ואז כסף וכוסף מדת החסד תועפות לך ע״כ

The Midrash on Psalms teaches: When a person is ill for one day, what should they do? They need prayer. The same applies on the second day and the third day. On the fourth day, what should they do? They should declare, "I am in pain." The Holy One, blessed be He, then says, "Now I will support and restore him." This is the meaning of "You have turned his entire bed in his illness." All the sins that one committed while standing on their feet, the Holy One turns around through their illness.[2] Therefore, one who sets their ways properly[A] will see God's salvation. And they said in the Sanhedrin: Anyone who strengthens themselves in prayer below will have no adversaries above, as it is said, "Will your cry arrange itself when there is no distress? Then Shaddai will be among your gold." Then silver and longing—the attribute of kindness—will be treasures

[A] Or: "one who orders their path correctly" — This Aramaic expression could be rendered more literally to preserve the path metaphor, which connects to the theme of spiritual journey central to Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] This unusual phrase draws on Isaiah 29:4, which uses the image of a voice speaking from the dust. The author employs this self-deprecating metaphor to present himself humbly while still asserting the value of his teachings.

[2] This presents illness as a means of atonement—not merely punishment but a transformative process that can convert past sins into merit through proper spiritual response. This redemptive view of suffering is central to the book's approach to end-of-life care.

[i] Cf. Proverbs 11:3 — The author begins with an allusion to this biblical verse to emphasize the spiritual guidance that righteousness provides, setting the tone for a text that will offer spiritual guidance for the dying. | Cf. Job 20:17 — This biblical imagery is repurposed to describe the spiritual nourishment that readers will receive from the book's teachings about death and the afterlife. | Cf. Traditional Jewish blessing formulas — The author uses traditional blessing formulas to close this introductory section, establishing the religious authority of the text while invoking divine blessing on its readers.

[ii] The text presents a structured progression of illness over four days, showing that divine intervention typically occurs on the fourth day. This follows a pattern found in other rabbinic literature where significant spiritual transformations occur after three-day periods.

[iii] This is a quote from Psalms 41:4. The midrash interprets 'turning his bed' metaphorically to mean that God transforms the person's sins through their illness, making illness a form of atonement.

[iv] This is a quote from Job 36:19 that is creatively interpreted through wordplay. The original meaning refers to distress and riches, but the author reinterprets it to suggest that prayer eliminates adversaries (צרים) and brings divine protection.

רוח איש יכלכל מחלהו ודאי
אך רוח נכאה מי ישאנה[i] ובזה
תגדל חולי הנפש מחולי הגוף כי
הגוף החולה תסבול הנפש ותחזק
לשאת אותו אבל חולי הנפש אין
הגוף יכול לסבול צרתה ואין
בידו להחזיק אותה והיה כמסוס
נוסס. עוד הורה לנו דעת המלך
החכם בפ׳ זה כי היצר הרע
שבלב האדם גורם לו לכלכל
ולזון ולהשאיר הדבר המחליאים
אותו כי ימשך אחר תאותו וריש
כל מרעין הוא המכניס בלבו
דאגת על שום דבר מדברי
העולם[ii] כי גורמת אשא דגרמי
כדכתיב ורוח נכאה תיבש גרם
ואמרו החכמים שהדאגה היא
מחלת הנפש ומי שדואג תמיד
נופל בחולאים רעים כדאמרו
רבנן בפ׳ הרואה ובפרק אע״פ
ובפרק חלק בדברי בן סירא
ואמרו אין עם הדאגה שכל.
וכשם שאנו נאים בטובה כך
נהיה נאים בפורעניות. ואמרו
במדרש תהלים ואתה מרום
לעולם ה׳ לעולם ידך על עילתא
על הטוב ברוך הטוב והמטיב.
על הרע ברוך דיין האמת.
ע״כ למשופטנו נתחנן כי טובו
וחסדו יראה אב הרחמן רופא

for you.[A] Thus, "A man's spirit can sustain him in sickness," but "a broken spirit, who can bear it?" In this way, sickness of the soul is greater than sickness of the body,[1] for when the body is sick, the soul can endure and strengthen itself to bear it, but when the soul is sick, the body cannot endure its distress nor sustain it, and it becomes like a melting standard.[B]

Furthermore, the wise king taught us in this verse that the evil inclination in a person's heart causes them to nourish and sustain the very things that make them ill, as they follow their desires. The root of all sickness is worry about worldly matters,[2] for it causes "burning of the bones," as it is written, "A broken spirit dries the bones." The sages said that worry is a sickness of the soul, and one who constantly worries falls into terrible illnesses, as our rabbis stated in chapter "The Seer," in chapter "Even Though," and in chapter "Portion" in the words of Ben Sira. And they said, "There is no wisdom with worry." Just as we are beautiful in good times, so should we be beautiful in suffering.[3]

They also said in the Midrash on Psalms: "And You, O Lord, are exalted forever." Forever Your hand is supreme—for good, "Blessed is the Good who does good"; for evil, "Blessed is the True Judge." Therefore we entreat our Judge that the Merciful Father, the Healer, show His goodness and kindness, and let the crushed bones rejoice. May He send His good word and heal the sickness of His people, for there is none besides Him. And it seems to me that for

[A] Or: "silver and the yearning quality of loving-kindness will be abundant treasures for you" — This alternate translation makes clearer that 'longing' (בוסף) is being presented as a characteristic of the divine attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness), and 'toa'fot' specifically implies abundant treasures.

[B] Or: "it becomes like a dissolving banner" — This biblical allusion (likely to Isaiah 10:18) uses the image of a flag or banner (נס/nes) that is wasting away, which might be clearer with this alternate translation.

[1] The author establishes a hierarchy of suffering where spiritual distress is considered more severe than physical pain, because the soul can strengthen itself to endure physical illness, but the body lacks the capacity to support spiritual suffering.

[2] This reflects a psychosomatic understanding of illness that was advanced for its time, recognizing how mental states (particularly anxiety) can manifest as physical ailments.

[3] This phrase reflects the Jewish concept of accepting both good and bad with equanimity, suggesting that one should maintain dignity and spiritual composure even during suffering.

[i] A quote from Proverbs 18:14, used to establish the comparison between physical and spiritual illness. The author argues that spiritual illness is worse because while the soul can support a sick body, the body cannot sustain a sick soul.

[ii] The author presents an important psychological insight that worldly worries are the root cause of many physical ailments, anticipating modern understandings of psychosomatic illness.

ותגלנה עצמות המדוכים וישלח
דברו הטוב וירפא חולי עמו כי
אין עוד מלבדו: ונ״ל שלאיזה
חולאים זרים טוב להרגיל עצמו
בהתפללו לומר מלות אלו
אין עוד מלבדו כדא״ר חנילא
על החיא איתתא אי מסתייעת
זיל עביד אי״ן עו״ד מ״לבדו
כתי׳[i] וברצונו המרחם ירוחם כל
בעל מדוה וחולו אם אל אלוה
ישא פניו עם חצוצרות התרועה
אלו אשר בעניי הכינותי פני כל
חכם וסכל הנה הנם פסוקים
מיוחדים ומסוגלים להארת פני
הרצון העליון על כל מין מיחוש
ומדוה וחולי ומחלה כי רחמי
האל יקדמו פנימיותם הכמוס
בתוכם וגם פשטי דבריהם
יוציאו ממסגר אסיר וישלח דברו
וירפאם ומלאך פניו יושיעם
באהבתו ובחמלתו. בינו נא
בהם וחיו ותתענג בדשן נפשכם
וכונת מספרם ומפקדם בא בראש
הספר ממאמר שפתי צדק פרק
ו׳[ii] דרשו משם וחיו:[iii]

certain strange illnesses, it is good to accustom oneself when praying to say these words: "There is none besides Him,"[1] as Rabbi Chanila said regarding that 85R
woman, "If you want to succeed, go and perform [the formula] 'There is NONE BESIDES HIM'" as it is written, and through His mercy, the Compassionate One will have mercy on everyone afflicted with illness and disease if they lift their face to God. 90R

With trumpets of alarm, I have prepared in my poverty these verses for every wise and simple person. Behold, they are special verses uniquely suited to illuminate the countenance of the Supreme Will[2] for every type of ailment, disease, sickness, and mal- 95R
ady. For God's mercy precedes their hidden inner meaning, and even their plain meaning will free the prisoner. He will send His word and heal them, and His angel will save them through His love and compassion. Please understand them and live, and your 100R
soul will delight in abundance. The intention of their number and arrangement appears at the beginning of the book in the discourse "Lips of Righteousness," chapter 6—seek it there and live!

[1] This phrase (אין עוד מלבדו) from Deuteronomy 4:35 is presented as a specific healing formula. This reflects the kabbalistic practice of using divine names and biblical phrases as protective or healing invocations.

[2] The author presents a mystical understanding of biblical verses as channels for divine healing energy. The metaphor of 'illuminating the countenance' suggests that these verses activate divine favor (the 'shining face' of God referenced in the priestly blessing).

[i] This refers to a story about Rabbi Chanila who prescribed reciting the formula 'There is none besides Him' (אין עוד מלבדו) as a healing remedy. The quotation marks in the Hebrew indicate acronyms or special emphasis on these words as a formula to be recited.

[ii] The author refers readers to another section of his own book 'Ma'avar Yabok' titled 'Siftei Tzedek' (Lips of Righteousness), chapter 6, which apparently contains detailed explanations of healing verses and their arrangements.

[iii] Cf. Midrash Tehillim — The text draws on this midrash to establish the progressive nature of illness and divine response, showing how illness can serve as atonement for sins and how God ultimately provides support on the fourth day of illness. | Cf. Tractate Sanhedrin — This reference establishes the protective power of sincere prayer, suggesting that one who prays with full effort will be protected from spiritual accusers in the heavenly court. | Cf. Proverbs 18:14 — The author uses this verse as the foundation for comparing physical and spiritual illness, arguing that spiritual affliction is more severe because while the soul can support a sick body, the body cannot support a sick soul. | Cf. Berakhot — The author refers to this section to establish rabbinic precedent for the harmful effects of worry on health, supporting his argument that psychological states directly impact physical wellbeing. | Cf. Ben Sira — This reference to Ben Sira's wisdom reinforces the connection between worry and illness, drawing on non-canonical but respected Jewish wisdom literature. | Cf. Psalm 68:14 — The author reinterprets this verse through wordplay to suggest that sincere prayer turns potential adversaries (צרים) into treasures (בצריך), showing how prayer transforms negative circumstances into spiritual wealth. | Cf. Siftei Tzedek — The author refers readers to this earlier section of his own work for the detailed explanation of the biblical verses that should be recited for healing various illnesses.

קודם שיתחיל כל סדר יאמר זה[i][ii]

Before beginning each order, one should say this[A] 105R

יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא: ג״פ[iii] יְיָ שִׁמְעָה־תְפִלָּתִי
יְיָ וְשַׁוְעָתִי הַאֲזִינָה אֶל־דִּמְעָתִי
אַל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ כִּי גֵר אָנֹכִי עִמָּךְ
תּוֹשָׁב כְּכָל־אֲבוֹתָי: כְּסוּס עָגוּר
כֵּן אֲצַפְצֵף[iv] אֶהְגֶּה כַּיּוֹנָה
דַּלּוּ עֵינַי לָמָרוֹם יְיָ עָשְׁקָה־לִּי
עָרְבֵנִי: כִּי לֹא שְׁאוֹל תּוֹדֶךָּ מָוֶת
יְהַלְלֶךָּ לֹא־יְשַׂבְּרוּ יוֹרְדֵי־בוֹר
אֶל־אֲמִתֶּךָ[v]: יְיָ לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי
וּנְגִנוֹתַי נְנַגֵּן כָּל־יְמֵי חַיֵּינוּ
עַל־בֵּית יְיָ: אַל־תַּעַזְבֵנִי יְיָ אֱלֹהַי

Please, O LORD, save us! [3 times][B] Hear my prayer,
O LORD, and give ear to my cry; do not be silent
at my tears, for I am a stranger with You, a so-
journer like all my fathers. Like a horse or a crane,
so do I chirp;[C] I moan like a dove; my eyes grow dim 110R
looking upward; O LORD, I am oppressed, be my
surety.[D] For the grave does not thank You, death
does not praise You; those who descend to the pit do
not hope for Your truth.[1] O LORD, save me, and
we will play my music all the days of our lives at the 115R
house of the LORD.[2] Do not forsake me, O LORD

[A] Or: "Before commencing any of these prayer sequences, one should recite the following" — This alternate translation captures the liturgical context more clearly, specifying that these are prayer sequences rather than just 'orders,' and using 'recite' instead of 'say' better reflects the formal religious nature of the instruction.

[B] Or: "three times" — The abbreviation ג״פ (gimmel-peh) stands for 'three times' (pa'amim shalosh). While the bracketed notation is accurate, spelling it out would be clearer for readers unfamiliar with Hebrew abbreviations.

[C] Or: "Like a swift or a swallow, so do I chirp" — The Hebrew terms 'sus' and 'agur' have been variously translated. While 'horse' is one translation of 'sus', in this context from Isaiah 38:14, many scholars believe it refers to 'swift' (a type of bird). Similarly, 'agur' is sometimes translated as 'crane' but also as 'swallow'. Bird imagery makes more contextual sense with the chirping.

[D] Or: "I am oppressed, be my guarantor" — The Hebrew 'arveni' (עָרְבֵנִי) literally means 'be my guarantor' or 'stand surety for me'. Both translations are accurate, but 'guarantor' might be more immediately understandable to modern readers.

[1] This biblical passage is frequently cited in Jewish sources discussing why recovery from illness is desirable—not merely for the person's physical wellbeing, but because the living have the unique privilege of praising God and studying Torah, activities unavailable to the dead according to this worldview.

[2] This phrase suggests that recovery from illness would result in continued worship at the Temple (or synagogue in post-Temple times). It reflects the book's perspective that proper spiritual care during illness focuses on both potential outcomes: recovery with renewed commitment to divine service, or a spiritually prepared transition to death.

[i] This is a liturgical instruction (rubric) at the beginning of the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok, indicating that each of the eight prayer arrangements should begin with the formula that follows this instruction.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This line serves as a liturgical instruction indicating that each of the eight prayer sequences that follow should be preceded by a specific opening formula. Such rubrics were common in Jewish prayer books to ensure proper ritual practice. | Cf. Siddur (Jewish prayer book) — This instructional text follows the format commonly found in Jewish prayer books, where rubrics in Hebrew indicate the proper order and procedure for prayer sequences.

[iii] The Hebrew instruction "ג״פ" (gimmel-peh) indicates that the phrase "Please, O LORD, save us" should be recited three times. This repetition is common in Jewish liturgy for particularly important supplications.

[iv] This is a direct quote from Isaiah 38:14, part of King Hezekiah's prayer when he was deathly ill. The specific bird types mentioned have been variously translated, but the imagery conveys the desperate, repetitive sounds of someone in distress.

[v] This reflects the traditional Jewish concept that divine praise is primarily performed by the living, not the dead. In the context of prayers for healing, it suggests that recovery would allow continued service to God, a core theme in Ma'avar Yabok.

אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי: חוּשָׁה לְעֶזְרָתִי יְיָ תְּשׁוּעָתִי: [i]

my God, do not be far from me. Hasten to my aid, O LORD my salvation.

יאמר מזמור סימן י״ג או ט״ו או ט״ז או י״ז.[ii]

One should recite a psalm,[1] either number 13, 15, 16, or 17.[2] 120R

(תהלים יג) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד: עַד־אָנָה יְיָ תִּשְׁכָּחֵנִי נֶצַח[iii] עַד־אָנָה תַּסְתִּיר אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי: עַד־אָנָה אָשִׁית עֵצוֹת בְּנַפְשִׁי יָגוֹן בִּלְבָבִי יוֹמָם עַד־אָנָה יָרוּם אֹיְבִי עָלָי: הַבִּיטָה עֲנֵנִי יְיָ אֱלֹהָי הָאִירָה עֵינַי פֶּן־אִישַׁן הַמָּוֶת[iv]: פֶּן־יֹאמַר אֹיְבִי יְכָלְתִּיו צָרַי יָגִילוּ כִּי אֶמּוֹט: וַאֲנִי בְּחַסְדְּךָ בָטַחְתִּי יָגֵל לִבִּי בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ אָשִׁירָה לַיְיָ כִּי

(Psalm 13) For the Chief Musician, a psalm of David. How long, O LORD, will You forget me forever? How long will You hide Your face from me? How long shall I take counsel in my soul,[A] having sorrow in my heart daily? How long will my enemy be exalted over me? Consider and answer me, O LORD my God;[B] enlighten my eyes, lest I sleep the sleep of death. Lest my enemy say, "I have prevailed over him," and my adversaries rejoice when I am shaken. But I have trusted in Your mercy; my heart shall 125R 130R

[A] Or: "How long must I devise strategies within myself" — This alternate translation emphasizes the active, repetitive mental struggle of the ill person trying to find solutions to their suffering, which might better convey the psychological dimension of illness that Ma'avar Yabok addresses.

[B] Or: "Look upon me and answer me, O LORD my God" — This translation more directly captures the visual metaphor in הַבִּיטָה (literally "look") which contrasts with God "hiding His face" mentioned earlier, emphasizing the sick person's desire to be seen by God in their suffering.

[1] The Hebrew uses the third-person masculine singular imperfect verb 'יאמר' (yomar), which could be translated as 'he should say' or 'one should recite.' In the context of a liturgical manual, this is a directive to whoever is performing the ritual.

[2] These psalm numbers refer to specific psalms that would be appropriate for situations of illness or approaching death. Psalm 13 is a plea for divine help during suffering, Psalm 15 describes who may dwell with God, Psalm 16 expresses confidence in God's protection even in death, and Psalm 17 is a prayer for divine protection against enemies.

[i] Cf. Psalms 39:12 — This verse expresses the supplicant's sense of transience and mortality, a fitting sentiment for Ma'avar Yabok as it deals with end-of-life transitions. The reference emphasizes the petitioner's vulnerable position before God. | Cf. Isaiah 38:14 — This passage is drawn from King Hezekiah's prayer when he was deathly ill, making it particularly appropriate for Ma'avar Yabok's focus on prayers for the sick and dying. The imagery of birds expressing distress symbolizes the human cry of pain and supplication. | Cf. Isaiah 38:18-19 — This verse from Hezekiah's prayer reflects the traditional Jewish view that divine praise is primarily the domain of the living. It subtly suggests urgency in healing the sick, as recovery would allow continued service to God, a theme emphasized throughout Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Psalm 38:21-22 — This concluding plea from Psalm 38 is particularly relevant in the context of illness or approaching death. The psalmist, who describes intense suffering throughout the psalm, ends with this direct appeal for divine presence and swift help.

[ii] This is an instruction within the "Seder" (ordered arrangement) section of Ma'avar Yabok, directing the reader to select one of four specific psalms to recite when visiting the sick or attending to the dying. The term 'סימן' (siman) refers to the chapter number of the psalm in the biblical Book of Psalms.

[iii] The repetition of "how long" (עַד־אָנָה) four times in the opening verses creates a rhythmic lament that expresses the sick person's feeling of abandonment and impatience for divine intervention. This rhetorical device was considered particularly powerful in healing prayers.

[iv] The Hebrew phrase uses "sleep the sleep of death" as a euphemism. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this takes on special significance as a prayer against dying unprepared or without divine reconciliation.

[i] גָּמַל עָלָי׃

rejoice in Your salvation. I will sing to the LORD, because He has dealt bountifully with me.[1]

(תהלים טו) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד יְיָ
מִי־יָגוּר בְּאָהֳלֶךָ מִי־יִשְׁכֹּן בְּהַר
קָדְשֶׁךָ[ii]׃ הוֹלֵךְ תָּמִים וּפֹעֵל צֶדֶק
וְדֹבֵר אֱמֶת בִּלְבָבוֹ׃ לֹא־רָגַל
עַל־לְשֹׁנוֹ לֹא־עָשָׂה לְרֵעֵהוּ רָעָה
וְחֶרְפָּה לֹא־נָשָׂא עַל־קְרֹבוֹ׃ נִבְזֶה
בְּעֵינָיו נִמְאָס וְאֶת־יִרְאֵי יְיָ יְכַבֵּד
נִשְׁבַּע לְהָרַע וְלֹא יָמֵר׃ כַּסְפּוֹ
לֹא־נָתַן בְּנֶשֶׁךְ[iii] וְשֹׁחַד עַל־נָקִי
לֹא לָקָח עֹשֵׂה־אֵלֶּה לֹא יִמּוֹט
לְעוֹלָם׃[iv] [v]

(Psalm 15) A Psalm of David. LORD, who may dwell in Your tent?[2] Who may abide on Your holy mountain? One who walks uprightly, and does what is right, and speaks truth in his heart.[3] Who has not slandered with his tongue, has not done harm to his fellow, nor cast disgrace upon his relative. In whose eyes a contemptible person is despised,[A] but who honors those who fear the LORD; who swears to his own detriment and does not change.[4] Who has not lent his money with interest,[B] nor taken a bribe against the innocent. One who does these things

[A] Or: "In whose eyes a vile person is despised" — The Hebrew term 'nivzeh' can be rendered as 'vile' which might better capture the moral judgment implied in the original, though 'contemptible' maintains the formal register appropriate for this translation.

[B] Or: "has not given with usury" — The term 'neshekh' literally means 'bite' and is sometimes translated as 'usury' rather than 'interest' to emphasize its exploitative nature. However, 'interest' is more immediately understandable to modern readers.

[1] The Hebrew גָּמַל עָלָי could also be translated as "rewarded me" or "bestowed good upon me." The psalm concludes with an expression of hope and gratitude that would be recited even by the seriously ill, affirming faith in divine goodness despite present suffering.

[2] The Hebrew 'mi-yagur be'ohalekha' uses imagery of temporary dwelling (tent) that would resonate with the sick person contemplating the temporary nature of physical existence.

[3] The internal dimension of truth-speaking is emphasized here, suggesting that genuine ethical conduct begins with internal honesty. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on genuine confession and self-examination before death.

[4] This refers to keeping one's word even when it becomes disadvantageous—a particularly significant virtue in Jewish tradition regarding deathbed promises and ethical wills.

[i] Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 7b — This psalm is understood in rabbinic tradition as David's prayer during a time of spiritual and physical crisis. Ma'avar Yabok includes it specifically to give voice to the sick person's feelings of abandonment during illness while maintaining hope in divine mercy. | Cf. Zohar II 218b — In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this psalm gives expression to the sick person's experience of divine concealment, which kabbalistic tradition understands as a necessary phase before healing or peaceful transition. The repeated 'how long' questions mirror the soul's longing for divine reconnection.

[ii] This question about dwelling on God's holy mountain has special resonance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it evokes the soul's journey to divine realms after death. The psalm functions as both a moral examination for the ill person and a meditation on the spiritual prerequisites for the soul's ascent.

[iii] The prohibition against lending with interest appears frequently in burial society (chevra kadisha) ethical codes, as they often functioned as interest-free loan societies. This reinforces Ma'avar Yabok's connection to these societies who would recite these prayers.

[iv] The Hebrew 'lo yimot le'olam' (shall never be shaken) can be read as a promise of spiritual stability beyond death. In the context of prayers for the ill, this offers reassurance that ethical conduct provides lasting spiritual security.

[v] Cf. Psalm 24 — Both psalms describe ethical qualifications for proximity to God. This connection is especially relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as these qualifications may represent the spiritual preparation needed for the soul's final journey. | Cf. Zohar — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok likely draws on kabbalistic interpretations where the ethical qualities described serve as 'passport credentials' for the soul entering heavenly realms. | Cf. Talmud — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm represents a moral summation that prepares the sick or dying person by focusing on essential ethical conduct rather than complex ritual details.

shall never be shaken.

(תהלים טז) מִכְתָּם לְדָוִד[i] שָׁמְרֵנִי
אֵל כִּי־חָסִיתִי בָךְ: אָמַרְתְּ לַיְיָ אֲדֹנָי
אָתָּה טוֹבָתִי בַּל־עָלֶיךָ: לִקְדוֹשִׁים
אֲשֶׁר־בָּאָרֶץ הֵמָּה וְאַדִּירֵי
כָּל־חֶפְצִי־בָם[ii]: יִרְבּוּ עַצְּבוֹתָם
אַחֵר מָהָרוּ[iii] בַּל־אַסִּיךְ נְסָכֵיהֶם
מִדָּם וּבַל־אֶשָּׂא אֶת־שְׁמוֹתָם
עַל־שְׂפָתָי: יְיָ מְנָת־חֶלְקִי וְכוֹסִי
אַתָּה תּוֹמִיךְ גּוֹרָלִי: חֲבָלִים
נָפְלוּ־לִי בַּנְּעִמִים אַף־נַחֲלָת
שָׁפְרָה עָלָי: אֲבָרֵךְ אֶת־יְיָ אֲשֶׁר
יְעָצָנִי אַף־לֵילוֹת יִסְּרוּנִי כִלְיוֹתָי:
שִׁוִּיתִי יְיָ לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד כִּי מִימִינִי
בַּל־אֶמּוֹט: לָכֵן שָׂמַח לִבִּי וַיָּגֶל
כְּבוֹדִי[iv] אַף־בְּשָׂרִי יִשְׁכֹּן לָבֶטַח:
כִּי לֹא־תַעֲזֹב נַפְשִׁי לִשְׁאוֹל
לֹא־תִתֵּן חֲסִידְךָ לִרְאוֹת שָׁחַת[v]:

(Psalm 16) A miktam of David. Protect me, O God, 145R
for I have taken refuge in You. I said to the LORD,
"You are my Lord; my wellbeing is not incumbent
upon You.[A] As for the holy ones who are in the
earth, they are the noble ones in whom is all my
delight.[B] The sorrows of those who hasten after 150R
another [god] will increase;[C] I will not pour out their
libations of blood, nor will I bear their names upon
my lips. The LORD is my portion and my cup; You
support my lot. Boundary lines have fallen for me
in pleasant places;[1] indeed, I have a beautiful inheri- 155R
tance. I will bless the LORD who has counseled me;
even at night my innermost being instructs me. I
have set the LORD before me always; because He is
at my right hand, I shall not be shaken. Therefore
my heart rejoices and my glory exults;[2] my flesh, too, 160R
dwells securely.[D] For You will not abandon my soul

[A] Or: "I said to the LORD, "You are my Lord; I have no good beyond You."" — This alternate translation captures another widely accepted interpretation of this difficult verse, suggesting that the psalmist finds all good in God alone, rather than expressing that God has no obligation toward the psalmist. This reading emphasizes the sufficiency of God rather than divine grace.

[B] Or: "As for the saints who are in the land, they are the excellent ones in whom is all my delight." — This translation uses terms more familiar in religious contexts ('saints' rather than 'holy ones' and 'excellent ones' rather than 'noble ones'). It also specifies 'the land' which might suggest the promised land of Israel rather than earth generally, which could better reflect the original context.

[C] Or: "Many are the sorrows of those who pursue another god" — This simpler rendering avoids some of the syntactical complexity of the Hebrew while preserving the essential meaning. It may be more accessible to modern readers while still accurately conveying the contrast between worshipping the true God and following idols.

[D] Or: "even my body rests in safety" — This alternate translation might better convey the

[1] The "boundary lines" refer to how land was distributed by lot in ancient Israel, using measuring lines to mark property boundaries. The psalmist uses this as a metaphor for his spiritual inheritance, suggesting that God has given him a favorable portion in life.

[2] In biblical Hebrew, "glory" (כָּבוֹד) can refer to one's innermost self or soul, representing the seat of emotions and honor. Some traditions understand this as referring to the tongue or faculty of speech, suggesting that the psalmist praises God verbally.

[i] The term "miktam" (מִכְתָּם) is a technical musical or liturgical term whose exact meaning is uncertain. It appears in the titles of Psalms 16, 56-60. Some scholars suggest it refers to an inscription or a golden psalm, while others connect it to the verb meaning "to cover" or "to hide," possibly suggesting a hidden or secret teaching.

[ii] This verse has challenging syntax in the Hebrew. It could refer to the righteous people in the land whom the psalmist admires, or possibly to other divine beings ("holy ones") whom the psalmist acknowledges without worshipping.

[iii] This is one of the more difficult verses to translate in this psalm. The Hebrew syntax is compressed and potentially ambiguous, with several possible interpretations about who is being referred to and what action is being described.

[iv] The Hebrew term "כְּבוֹדִי" (my glory) likely refers to the psalmist's soul or innermost self, though some translations render it as "tongue" based on similar usage elsewhere in Psalms.

[v] This verse is quoted in Acts 2:27 and 13:35 in the New Testament as a messianic prophecy referring to Christ's resurrection, though in its original context it may express confidence in divine protection from premature death.

תּוֹדִיעֵנִי אֹרַח חַיִּים שֹׂבַע שְׂמָחוֹת
אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ נְעִמוֹת בִּימִינְךָ נֶצַח: [i]

to Sheol, nor will You allow Your faithful one to see the pit.[A] You will make known to me the path of life; in Your presence is fullness of joy; at Your right hand are pleasures forevermore." 165R

(תהלים יז) תְּפִלָּה לְדָוִד[ii] שְׁמַע
יְיָ צֶדֶק הַקְשִׁיבָה רִנָּתִי[iii] הַאֲזִינָה
תְּפִלָּתִי בְּלֹא שִׂפְתֵי מִרְמָה[iv]:
מִלְּפָנֶיךָ מִשְׁפָּטִי יֵצֵא עֵינֶיךָ
תֶּחֱזֶינָה מֵישָׁרִים: בָּחַנְתָּ לִבִּי
פָּקַדְתָּ לַיְלָה[v] צְרַפְתַּנִי בַל־תִּמְצָא
זַמֹּתִי בַּל־יַעֲבָר־פִּי: לִפְעֻלוֹת אָדָם
בִּדְבַר שְׂפָתֶיךָ אֲנִי שָׁמַרְתִּי אָרְחוֹת
פָּרִיץ: תָּמֹךְ אֲשֻׁרַי בְּמַעְגְּלוֹתֶיךָ
בַּל־נָמוֹטוּ פְּעָמָי: אֲנִי־קְרָאתִיךָ
כִּי־תַעֲנֵנִי אֵל הַט־אָזְנְךָ לִי שְׁמַע
אִמְרָתִי: הַפְלֵה חֲסָדֶיךָ מוֹשִׁיעַ

(Psalm 17) A prayer of David.[1] Hear, O LORD, righteousness, attend to my cry, give ear to my prayer from lips without deceit. Let my judgment come forth from Your presence; let Your eyes behold what is right. You have examined my heart, You have 170R visited me in the night, You have tested me and found nothing; my thoughts do not transgress my mouth. As for the deeds of men, by the word of Your lips I have kept myself from the paths of the violent. My steps have held fast to Your paths, 175R my feet have not slipped. I have called upon You, for You will answer me, O God; incline Your ear

sense of complete physical security and peace that the psalmist feels. The term 'rests' connotes the peaceful confidence more clearly than 'dwells' for contemporary readers, while 'safety' may be more immediately understood than 'securely.'

[A] Or: "For You will not abandon me to the grave, nor let Your faithful one experience decay." — This translation avoids the potentially unfamiliar term 'Sheol' and captures the possible implications about bodily corruption or decay that are present in the Hebrew 'שָׁחַת' (shachat). This reading aligns with how the verse was later interpreted in Jewish and Christian traditions regarding resurrection.

[1] This psalm is specifically labeled as a prayer (tefillah) rather than a song, giving it a particularly supplicatory nature that made it appropriate for those who are ill or in distress.

[i] Cf. Psalm 17:8 — Both psalms open with similar petitions for divine protection, using different metaphorical language but expressing the same core trust in God's protective care. | Cf. Psalm 73:25-26 — Both psalms express the idea that God himself, rather than material benefits or other gods, is the psalmist's chosen portion and inheritance. This reflects the profound theological concept that relationship with God is the ultimate good. | Cf. Acts 2:25-28 — While not part of the original context, this later interpretation in the New Testament shows how Psalm 16 came to be understood messianically in early Christian tradition, particularly the references to not seeing corruption and the path of life. | Cf. Lamentations 3:24 — Both texts express the theological concept of God himself being one's inheritance or portion, a spiritual understanding of divine relationship that transcends material possessions or temporary circumstances. | Cf. Numbers 18:20 — Psalm 16:5's description of the LORD as 'my portion and my cup' echoes the language used about the Levitical priesthood, who had no land inheritance but instead had God as their portion. The psalmist adopts this priestly language to express complete dependence on and satisfaction with God.

[ii] This psalm is identified as a 'tefillah' (prayer) rather than a 'mizmor' (psalm), indicating its particularly supplicatory nature. It appears in Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick.

[iii] The term 'rinnati' (my cry) derives from a root suggesting joyful singing, but in this context refers to an intense, emotional plea—highlighting the psalmist's passionate appeal to God in a time of distress.

[iv] The phrase 'without deceitful lips' establishes the psalm's theme of innocence and integrity, which would resonate with the sick person seeking to present themselves honestly before God prior to potential death.

[v] The reference to God visiting or examining the psalmist at night has particular significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as nighttime was considered especially dangerous for the ill, when the Angel of Death was thought to be most active.

חוֹסִים מִמִּתְקוֹמְמִים בִּימִינֶךָ:
שָׁמְרֵנִי כְּאִישׁוֹן בַּת־עָיִן [i] בְּצֵל
כְּנָפֶיךָ תַּסְתִּירֵנִי [ii]: מִפְּנֵי רְשָׁעִים
זוֹ שַׁדּוּנִי אֹיְבַי בְּנֶפֶשׁ יַקִּיפוּ
עָלַי [iii]: חֶלְבָּמוֹ סָגָרוּ פִּימוֹ דִּבְּרוּ
בְגַאוּת: אַשֻּׁרֵינוּ עַתָּה סְבָבוּנִי
[סַבְּבוּנוּ] עֵינֵיהֶם יָשִׁיתוּ לִנְטוֹת
בָּאָרֶץ: דִּמְיוֹנוֹ כְּאַרְיֵה יִכְסוֹף
לִטְרוֹף [iv] וְכִכְפִיר יֹשֵׁב בְּמִסְתָּרִים:
קוּמָה יְיָ קַדְּמָה פָּנָיו הַכְרִיעֵהוּ
פַּלְּטָה נַפְשִׁי מֵרָשָׁע חַרְבֶּךָ: מִמְתִים
יָדְךָ יְיָ מִמְתִים מֵחֶלֶד [v] חֶלְקָם
בַּחַיִּים וצפינך [וּצְפוּנְךָ] תְּמַלֵּא
בִטְנָם יִשְׂבְּעוּ בָנִים וְהִנִּיחוּ יִתְרָם
לְעוֹלְלֵיהֶם: אֲנִי בְּצֶדֶק אֶחֱזֶה
פָּנֶיךָ אֶשְׂבְּעָה בְהָקִיץ תְּמוּנָתֶךָ [i] [ii]:

to me, hear my speech. Show Your wondrous lovingkindness, O Savior of those who seek refuge from their adversaries at Your right hand. Guard me as 180R
the apple of the eye;[1] hide me under the shadow of Your wings,[2] from the wicked who despoil me, my deadly enemies who surround me. They have closed their unfeeling heart;[3] with their mouth they speak proudly. They have now surrounded our steps; they 185R
set their eyes to cast us down to the ground. He is like a lion that is eager to tear, and like a young lion lurking in hiding places. Arise, O LORD, confront him, bring him low; deliver my soul from the wicked with Your sword, from men by Your hand, O 190R
LORD, from men of the world whose portion is in this life,[4] and whose belly You fill with Your treasure; they are satisfied with children, and leave their abundance to their infants. As for me, I shall behold Your face in righteousness; I will be satisfied, when 195R
I awake, with Your likeness.[5]

[1] This evocative phrase translates the Hebrew ‘ishon bat-ayin,’ literally ‘the little man of the daughter of the eye,’ referring to the pupil where one can see a tiny reflection of oneself. It’s an ancient metaphor for something precious and carefully protected.

[2] This protective imagery appears frequently in psalms and was especially meaningful in the context of Ma’avar Yabok, where being ‘under the wings of the Divine Presence’ symbolized spiritual protection during illness and at the moment of death.

[3] The Hebrew ‘chelbamo sagru’ literally refers to ‘closing their fat,’ with ‘fat’ symbolizing insensitivity or callousness. The image suggests enemies who have become morally numb and incapable of compassion.

[4] This passage contrasts worldly people who find their satisfaction in material wealth and offspring with the psalmist, who seeks divine presence. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this reinforces the spiritual focus needed when facing illness and mortality.

[1] This final verse was particularly significant in the context of Ma’avar Yabok’s focus on death and the afterlife. While it literally refers to awakening from sleep, Jewish tradition often interpreted it as referring to resurrection or the soul’s experience after death, offering comfort to the ill person that even if they die, they will ‘awaken’ to divine presence.

[i] This phrase literally means ‘guard me like the pupil of the eye’ and uses the anatomical metaphor of the most protected and vulnerable part of the body to request divine protection—particularly appropriate for the physically vulnerable ill person.

[ii] The imagery of hiding under God’s wings appears frequently in psalms and was especially significant in Ma’avar Yabok’s kabbalistic framework, where it symbolized being brought ‘under the wings of the Divine Presence’ during illness and at death.

[iii] The Hebrew ‘oyevai b’nefesh’ (my soul-enemies) refers to those who seek the psalmist’s life. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this would be interpreted both literally as human enemies and mystically as the negative spiritual forces (chitzonim) that threaten the soul during illness.

[iv] The lion metaphor resonates with kabbalistic traditions that sometimes portrayed the Angel of Death (Samael) as lion-like in his fierceness and predatory nature.

[v] This difficult verse can be understood as ‘from men by Your hand, O LORD, from men of the world/age.’ The term ‘meḥeled’ (from the world/duration) appears in the text with a variant spelling, reflecting the textual fluidity common in liturgical manuscripts.

(תורה)[iii] הַאֲזִינוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם
וַאֲדַבֵּרָה וְתִשְׁמַע הָאָרֶץ
אִמְרֵי־פִי[iv]: מִי־כָמֹכָה בָּאֵלִם
יְיָ מִי כָּמֹכָה נֶאְדָּר בַּקֹּדֶשׁ נוֹרָא
תְהִלֹּת עֹשֵׂה פֶלֶא[v]: יְמִינְךָ יְיָ
נֶאְדָּרִי בַכֹּחַ יְמִינְךָ יְיָ תִּרְעַץ
אוֹיֵב[vi]: וַאֲבָרֶכָה מְבָרְכֶיךָ
וּמְקַלֶּלְךָ אָאֹר וְנִבְרְכוּ בְךָ כֹּל

Give ear, O heavens,[A] and I will speak; and hear, O earth, the words of my mouth.[1] Who is like You among the mighty, O LORD?[B] Who is like You, glorious in holiness, awesome in praises,[C] working wonders?[2] Your right hand, O LORD, is majestic in strength; Your right hand, O LORD, shatters the enemy.[3] I will bless those who bless you, and whoever curses you I will curse; and in you all the families of 200R

[A] Or: "Listen, O heavens" — While 'give ear' is more poetically faithful to the Hebrew, 'listen' provides a more contemporary, accessible rendering that maintains the meaning without the archaic phrasing.

[B] Or: "Who is like You among the divine beings, O LORD?" — The Hebrew term 'eilim' (בָּאֵלִם) can refer either to the 'mighty ones' or more specifically to 'divine beings/gods.' The latter translation more explicitly acknowledges the biblical polytheistic context where YHWH is compared to other divine beings, which would be consistent with academic translations seeking to preserve original cultural contexts.

[C] Or: "inspiring awe through praises" — This alternative more clearly conveys that the praiseworthy acts themselves inspire awe, rather than suggesting that God is awesome while being praised. The Hebrew construction allows for this interpretive nuance.

[2] This powerful opening invokes heaven and earth as witnesses, a common biblical rhetorical device used in solemn proclamations. In the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this summons the entire cosmos to participate in the plea for healing.

[3] This phrase from the Song of the Sea (Shirat HaYam) invokes God's incomparable power to perform miracles. In healing prayers, it serves as a reminder that God's ability to heal transcends natural limitations.

[4] The repeated reference to God's "right hand" is significant in Jewish mystical tradition, where it represents the attribute of mercy (chesed) as opposed to the left hand of judgment (din). In healing contexts, this invokes God's merciful healing power rather than strict judgment.

[vi] The phrase 'when I awake, with Your likeness' was interpreted in Jewish tradition both as awakening from sleep and metaphorically as resurrection. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this verse would offer hope to the ill person that even if they die, they will 'awaken' to divine presence in the afterlife.

[vii] Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok would interpret the psalm's phrase 'under the shadow of Your wings' in light of this Zoharic teaching, where the divine wings represent the Shekhinah's protection over souls, particularly during illness and at the moment of death. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The themes of divine protection in Psalm 17 parallel those in Psalm 91, which is prominently featured elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences for the sick and dying. Both psalms use images of divine shelter and deliverance from enemies, which would be understood as protection from both physical affliction and spiritual dangers during illness. | Cf. Book of Job — The psalm's reference to God examining the heart, visiting at night, and testing resonates with Job's description of divine scrutiny. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this connection would suggest that illness, like Job's suffering, involves divine examination that ultimately leads to spiritual purification.

[i] This heading indicates that the following verses are specifically selected from the Torah (Pentateuch), the first five books of the Hebrew Bible. The Ma'avar Yabok organizes verses into three categories: Torah, Prophets (נביאים), and Writings (כתובים), following the traditional Jewish division of scripture.

[ii] This verse opens the Song of Moses in Deuteronomy 32:1, where heaven and earth are called as witnesses to God's covenant with Israel. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse invokes cosmic witnesses for the prayers being offered on behalf of the sick person.

[iii] From the Song of the Sea in Exodus 15:11, sung after the Israelites' deliverance at the Red Sea. In this context, it appeals to God's unparalleled power to perform wonders, specifically the wonder of healing.

[iv] From Exodus 15:6, continuing the Song of the Sea. The right hand in Jewish tradition symbolizes mercy and healing power. Here, the "enemy" can be interpreted as illness or death threatening the sick person.

מִשְׁפְּחֹת הָאֲדָמָה׃[i] קוּם הִתְהַלֵּךְ בָּאָרֶץ לְאָרְכָּהּ וּלְרָחְבָּהּ כִּי לְךָ אֶתְּנֶנָּה׃[ii] וְאֶעֶשְׂךָ לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל וַאֲבָרֶכְךָ וַאֲגַדְּלָה שְׁמֶךָ וֶהְיֵה
205 בְּרָכָה׃[iii][iv]

the earth shall be blessed.[1] Arise, walk through the land in its length and in its width, for I will give it to you. I will make you into a great nation, and I will bless you, and make your name great, and you shall be a blessing.[2] 205R

(נביאים) שִׁמְעוּ מְלָכִים הַאֲזִינוּ רוֹזְנִים אָנֹכִי לַיְיָ אָנֹכִי אָשִׁירָה אֲזַמֵּר לַיְיָ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל׃[v] אֵין־קָדוֹשׁ כַּיְיָ כִּי אֵין בִּלְתֶּךָ
210 וְאֵין צוּר כֵּאלֹהֵינוּ׃ יְיָ יֵחַתּוּ מְרִיבָיו עָלָיו בַּשָּׁמַיִם יַרְעֵם יְיָ יָדִין אַפְסֵי־אָרֶץ וְיִתֵּן־עֹז לְמַלְכּוֹ וְיָרֵם קֶרֶן מְשִׁיחוֹ׃[vi] וַיֹּאמֶר לוֹ יְיָ שָׁלוֹם לְךָ אַל־תִּירָא לֹא תָמוּת׃[vii]

Hear, O kings; give ear, O rulers; I, even I, will sing unto the LORD;[3] I will sing praise to the LORD, the God of Israel. There is none holy as the LORD, for there is none beside You; neither is there any rock like our God. The adversaries of the LORD shall be broken to pieces; out of heaven shall He thunder upon them.[4] The LORD shall judge the ends of the earth; and He shall give strength unto His king, and exalt the horn of His anointed.[5] And the LORD said 210R 215R

[1]This verse from God's covenant with Abraham carries special significance in healing prayers as it reminds of God's protective relationship with Israel and suggests that those who care for the sick (blessing them) will themselves receive blessing.

[2]The final phrase "you shall be a blessing" (והיה ברכה) takes on particular poignancy in the context of prayers for the sick, expressing hope that the ill person will recover to continue being a source of blessing to others.

[3]The repetition of 'I' (אָנֹכִי) in the Hebrew creates emphasis that the speaker is personally committed to praising God despite their circumstances, which models the attitude recommended for the sick person.

[4]The imagery of God 'thundering' from heaven portrays divine intervention as powerful and dramatic, suggesting that healing can come suddenly and decisively.

[5]The 'horn' (קֶרֶן) is a biblical symbol of strength and power. In healing contexts, this suggests

[v]From Genesis 12:3, God's promise to Abraham. In this context, it reminds of the covenantal relationship between God and the Jewish people, appealing to divine protection.

[i]From Genesis 13:17, God's instruction to Abraham to walk throughout the Promised Land. In the context of healing prayers, this may symbolize a hope for the sick person to regain mobility and strength.

[ii]From Genesis 12:2, the beginning of God's covenant with Abraham. The phrase "והיה ברכה" (and be a blessing) is particularly significant as it expresses hope that the sick person will recover and continue to be a source of blessing to others.

[iii]Cf. Deuteronomy 32:1 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves to invoke cosmic witnesses for the healing prayers, elevating the supplication to a cosmic level and emphasizing the solemnity of the appeal for divine intervention. | Cf. Exodus 15:11-12 — These verses recalling God's greatest miracle of salvation for the Israelites are repurposed in Ma'avar Yabok to invoke the same divine power for healing. The 'enemy' being shattered is implicitly reinterpreted as illness or the Angel of Death. | Cf. Genesis 12:2-3 — These verses remind the reader of the covenantal relationship between God and the Jewish people, serving as the basis for approaching God with requests for healing. They also suggest that caring for the sick fulfills the Abrahamic mission to be a blessing to others. | Cf. Genesis 13:17 — In the context of healing prayers, this verse is reimagined as a hope for physical restoration—that the sick person will regain the ability to rise and walk freely through the land. It transforms a verse about territorial possession into one about bodily autonomy and health.

[iv]This opening verse is taken from the Song of Deborah (Judges 5:3), a victory song after defeating Israel's enemies. Beginning with this powerful declaration establishes a tone of confidence and praise even in difficult circumstances.

[v]These verses from Hannah's prayer (1 Samuel 2:10) were spoken after she received her son Samuel following years of barrenness. In the context of illness, they portray physical afflictions as 'adversaries' that God has power to break apart.

[vi]This verse (Judges 6:23) was spoken to Gideon who feared he would die after seeing the angel of the LORD. Its inclusion here provides direct divine reassurance against the fear of death that often accompanies serious illness.

לֹא־יָמוּשׁ סֵפֶר הַתּוֹרָה הַזֶּה מִפִּיךָ
וְהָגִיתָ בּוֹ יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה לְמַעַן
תִּשְׁמֹר לַעֲשׂוֹת כְּכָל־הַכָּתוּב בּוֹ
כִּי־אָז תַּצְלִיחַ אֶת־דְּרָכֶךָ וְאָז
תַּשְׂכִּיל: וַיֹּאמֶר הָעָם אֶל־שָׁאוּל
הֲיוֹנָתָן יָמוּת אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה הַיְשׁוּעָה
הַגְּדוֹלָה הַזֹּאת בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל חָלִילָה
חַי־יְיָ אִם־יִפֹּל מִשַּׂעֲרַת רֹאשׁוֹ
אַרְצָה כִּי־עִם־אֱלֹהִים עָשָׂה
הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה וַיִּפְדּוּ הָעָם אֶת־יוֹנָתָן
וְלֹא־מֵת[i]: וַאֲמַרְתֶּם כֹּה לֶחָי
וְאַתָּה שָׁלוֹם וּבֵיתְךָ שָׁלוֹם וְכֹל
אֲשֶׁר־לְךָ שָׁלוֹם[ii]: אוֹדְךָ יְיָ כִּי
אָנַפְתָּ בִּי יָשָׁב אַפְּךָ וּתְנַחֲמֵנִי:
הִנֵּה אֵל יְשׁוּעָתִי אֶבְטַח וְלֹא
אֶפְחָד כִּי־עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ יְיָ
וַיְהִי־לִי לִישׁוּעָה: וּשְׁאַבְתֶּם־מַיִם
בְּשָׂשׂוֹן מִמַּעַיְנֵי הַיְשׁוּעָה[iii]: וְעַתָּה
הוֹאֵל וּבָרֵךְ אֶת־בֵּית עַבְדְּךָ
לִהְיוֹת לְעוֹלָם לְפָנֶיךָ כִּי־אַתָּה
אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהִים דִּבַּרְתָּ וּמִבִּרְכָתְךָ
יְבֹרַךְ בֵּית־עַבְדְּךָ לְעוֹלָם: וּפָנִיתָ
אֶל־תְּפִלַּת עַבְדְּךָ וְאֶל־תְּחִנָּתוֹ
יְיָ אֱלֹהָי לִשְׁמֹעַ אֶל־הָרִנָּה
וְאֶל־הַתְּפִלָּה אֲשֶׁר עַבְדְּךָ מִתְפַּלֵּל
לְפָנֶיךָ הַיּוֹם: [iv]

unto him: "Peace be unto you; fear not; you shall not die."[1] This book of the Torah shall not depart out 220R
of your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, that you may observe to do according to all that is written in it; for then you shall make your way prosperous, and then you shall have good success. And the people said unto Saul: "Shall Jonathan die, 225R
who has wrought this great salvation in Israel? Far from it! As the LORD lives, not one hair of his head shall fall to the ground; for he has worked with God this day."[2] So the people rescued Jonathan, and he did not die. And thus shall you say to him that lives: 230R
"Peace be to you, and peace be to your house, and peace be to all that you have." I will give thanks to You, O LORD, for though You were angry with me, Your anger is turned away,[3] and You comfort me. Behold, God is my salvation; I will trust, and will 235R
not be afraid; for the LORD GOD is my strength and song, and He is become my salvation. Therefore with joy shall you draw water out of the wells of salvation.[4] And now, be pleased to bless the house of Your servant, that it may continue forever before 240R
You; for You, O Lord GOD, have spoken it; and with Your blessing let the house of Your servant be blessed forever. And pay attention to the prayer of Your servant, and to his supplication, O LORD my

restoration of the sick person's diminished strength through divine favor.

[1]This direct divine reassurance against death would be particularly comforting for seriously ill individuals who fear their condition might be terminal.

[2]The Hebrew phrase 'עָשָׂה הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה' (worked/acted this day) suggests that divine deliverance comes through active partnership between human and divine efforts, a concept relevant to healing which requires both medical intervention and spiritual faith.

[3]This verse from Isaiah frames suffering as temporary divine displeasure that gives way to comfort, providing a theological framework for understanding illness as a transient state rather than a permanent condition.

[4]The Hebrew phrase 'מַעַיְנֵי הַיְשׁוּעָה' (wells of salvation) presents divine healing as an abundant resource that can be actively accessed, encouraging the sick person to participate in their own recovery through spiritual practices.

[i]This narrative (1 Samuel 14:45) describes how Jonathan was saved from execution by his father Saul. In the context of healing prayers, it serves as a powerful example of deliverance from a death sentence through divine intervention.

[ii]This threefold blessing of peace (shalom) from 1 Samuel 25:6 extends beyond physical healing to encompass the person's household and possessions, suggesting that true divine healing is comprehensive in nature.

[iii]This verse from Isaiah 12:3 uses the metaphor of drawing water from wells of salvation with joy. In healing contexts, it suggests that divine healing power is abundant like flowing water, and should be approached with joyful expectation rather than despair.

[iv]Cf. Book of Judges 5:3 — This opening verse from Deborah's triumphant song is used to begin this collection of prophetic verses, establishing a tone of divine praise and victory. Its inclusion suggests that the sick person should adopt a similar attitude of trust and praise despite their circumstances. | Cf. 1 Samuel 2:2 — Hannah's declaration of God's uniqueness and strength

God, to hearken to the cry and to the prayer[1] which Your servant prays before You this day. 245R

(כתובים)[i] קוֹלִי אֶל־יְיָ אֶקְרָא
וַיַּעֲנֵנִי מֵהַר קָדְשׁוֹ סֶלָה[ii]׃ בְּקָרְאִי
עֲנֵנִי אֱלֹהֵי צִדְקִי בַּצָּר הִרְחַבְתָּ
לִי חָנֵּנִי וּשְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי׃ אֲמָרַי
245 הַאֲזִינָה יְיָ בִּינָה הֲגִיגִי׃ הַקְשִׁיבָה
לְקוֹל שַׁוְעִי מַלְכִּי וֵאלֹהָי כִּי־אֵלֶיךָ
אֶתְפַּלָּל׃ יְיָ אַל־בְּאַפְּךָ תוֹכִיחֵנִי
וְאַל־בַּחֲמָתְךָ תְיַסְּרֵנִי׃ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי
בְּךָ חָסִיתִי הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי מִכָּל־רֹדְפַי
250 וְהַצִּילֵנִי׃ פֶּן־יִטְרֹף כְּאַרְיֵה נַפְשִׁי
מוֹשִׁיעַ יְשָׁרֵי־לֵב׃ שְׁמָאלוֹ תַּחַת
לְרֹאשִׁי וִימִינוֹ תְּחַבְּקֵנִי[iii]׃ הִנֵּה
מִטָּתוֹ שֶׁלִּשְׁלֹמֹה שִׁשִּׁים גִּבֹּרִים
סָבִיב לָהּ מִגִּבֹּרֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל׃ כֻּלָּם

(Writings) I called to the LORD with my voice,[2] and He answered me from His holy mountain. Selah. When I call, answer me, O God of my righteousness; You have relieved me in my distress; be gracious to 250R me and hear my prayer. Give ear to my words, O LORD, consider my meditation. Listen to the voice of my cry, my King and my God, for to You I will pray. O LORD, do not rebuke me in Your anger, nor chasten me in Your hot displeasure. O LORD 255R my God, in You I put my trust; save me from all those who persecute me, and deliver me. My shield is with God, who saves the upright in heart. His left hand is under my head, and His right hand embraces me.[A] Behold, Solomon's bed, with sixty mighty men 260R

[A] Or: "Let His left hand be under my head, and His right hand embrace me" — This could be translated in the jussive mood (expressing a wish) rather than the indicative, which would better reflect how it might function in a prayer context where the supplicant is seeking divine comfort rather than stating it as a present reality.

[1] The Hebrew distinguishes between 'רִנָּה' (cry/joyful shout) and 'תְּפִלָּה' (structured prayer), suggesting that God responds to both emotional outpourings and formal liturgical approaches, giving the sick person multiple ways to seek divine healing.

[2] This compilation of verses begins with expressions of confidence that God hears and answers prayer (Psalm 3:4), establishing a foundation of trust for the sick person or those praying on their behalf.

provides assurance that there is no divine power like God, establishing the theological foundation for trusting in divine healing power. | Cf. 1 Samuel 2:10 — This verse completes the reference to Hannah's prayer, showing God's authority over adversaries and ability to strengthen the faithful, which would comfort those facing illness. | Cf. Judges 6:23 — This verse provides direct divine reassurance against fear of death, making it particularly relevant for the sick and dying who might fear their condition. | Cf. Joshua 1:8 — This verse emphasizes the importance of Torah study and observance as a source of divine blessing and success, suggesting spiritual practices that might aid recovery. | Cf. 1 Samuel 14:45 — This narrative of Jonathan's rescue from death serves as a metaphor for divine deliverance from a death sentence, offering hope to the seriously ill. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:6 — This threefold peace blessing is included to invoke comprehensive wellbeing (shalom) for the sick person and their household. | Cf. Isaiah 12:1-3 — These verses transform divine anger into comfort and salvation, providing a spiritual framework for viewing illness as temporary and giving way to eventual deliverance. | Cf. 2 Samuel 7:29 — This prayer for enduring blessing connects immediate healing needs to long-term divine favor, emphasizing continuity of life rather than its end. | Cf. 1 Kings 8:28 — This concluding verse from Solomon's prayer expresses humility and dependence on divine attention, modeling how the sick should approach God with both cry (emotional appeal) and structured prayer.

[i] This Hebrew heading indicates that what follows is a collection of verses from the Ketuvim (Writings), the third section of the Hebrew Bible. In Ma'avar Yabok, this collection appears as part of a structured prayer sequence for the sick and dying.

[ii] Selah is a musical or liturgical notation that appears frequently in Psalms, likely indicating a pause, musical interlude, or shift in emphasis. Its exact meaning remains uncertain, but in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it creates natural pauses in the prayer sequence.

[iii] This verse from Song of Songs 2:6 shifts the text from psalms to a verse expressing intimate divine embrace. In the original context, it describes lovers, but here it's repurposed to describe God's tender care for the sick person.

אֲחֵזֵי חֶרֶב מְלֻמְּדֵי מִלְחָמָה אִישׁ
חַרְבּוֹ עַל־יְרֵכוֹ מִפַּחַד בַּלֵּילוֹת׃[i]
שִׂימֵנִי כַחוֹתָם עַל־לִבֶּךָ כַּחוֹתָם
עַל־זְרוֹעֶךָ כִּי־עַזָּה כַמָּוֶת אַהֲבָה
קָשָׁה כִשְׁאוֹל קִנְאָה רְשָׁפֶיהָ רִשְׁפֵּי
אֵשׁ שַׁלְהֶבֶתְיָה׃[ii] לִינִי הַלַּיְלָה
וְהָיָה בַבֹּקֶר אִם־יִגְאָלֵךְ טוֹב יִגְאָל
וְאִם־לֹא יַחְפֹּץ לְגָאֳלֵךְ וּגְאַלְתִּיךְ
אָנֹכִי חַי־יְיָ שִׁכְבִי עַד־הַבֹּקֶר׃[iii]
אֲנִי שָׁכַבְתִּי וָאִישָׁנָה הֱקִיצוֹתִי כִּי יְיָ
יִסְמְכֵנִי׃ חַסְדֵי יְיָ כִּי לֹא־תָמְנוּ כִּי
לֹא־כָלוּ רַחֲמָיו׃ חֲדָשִׁים לַבְּקָרִים
רַבָּה אֱמוּנָתֶךָ׃[iv] חֶלְקִי יְיָ אָמְרָה
נַפְשִׁי עַל־כֵּן אוֹחִיל לוֹ׃ וַאֲנִי
בְּרֹב חַסְדְּךָ אָבוֹא בֵיתֶךָ אֶשְׁתַּחֲוֶה
אֶל־הֵיכַל־קָדְשְׁךָ בְּיִרְאָתֶךָ׃ יְיָ
נְחֵנִי בְצִדְקָתֶךָ לְמַעַן שׁוֹרְרָי הַיְשַׁר
לְפָנַי דַּרְכֶּךָ׃ כִּי־אַתָּה תְּבָרֵךְ
צַדִּיק יְיָ כַּצִּנָּה רָצוֹן תַּעְטְרֶנּוּ׃ לַיְיָ
הַיְשׁוּעָה עַל־עַמְּךָ בִרְכָתֶךָ סֶלָה׃
[i]

around it,[1] of the mighty men of Israel. They all hold swords, being expert in war; each man has his sword on his thigh because of fear in the night. Set me as a seal upon your heart, as a seal upon your arm; for love is as strong as death,[2] jealousy as cruel as the grave; its flames are flames of fire, a most vehement flame. Stay this night, and in the morning, if he will redeem you, good; let him redeem you. But if he is not willing to redeem you, then I will redeem you, as the LORD lives. Lie down until morning.[A] I lay down and slept; I awoke, for the LORD sustained me. The LORD's lovingkindnesses indeed never cease, for His compassions never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness.[3] "The LORD is my portion," says my soul, "Therefore I hope in Him." But as for me, I will come into Your house in the multitude of Your mercy; in fear of You I will worship toward Your holy temple. Lead me, O LORD, in Your righteousness because of my enemies; make Your way straight before my face. For You, O LORD, will bless the righteous; with favor You will surround him as with a shield. Salvation belongs to the LORD. Your blessing is upon Your people. Selah.[4]

[A] Or: "Remain this night, and when morning comes, if he redeems you, good; let him redeem you. But if he does not desire to redeem you, then I myself will redeem you, as the LORD lives. Rest until morning" — This alternate translation uses 'remain' and 'rest' instead of 'stay' and 'lie down,' which might better convey the spiritual comfort intended in this prayer context. The phrase 'when morning comes' rather than 'in the morning' emphasizes the certainty of dawn arriving, which symbolizes hope in a context of illness.

[1] This imagery from Song of Songs of warriors surrounding Solomon's bed takes on new meaning in the context of illness, symbolizing divine protection surrounding the sickbed. In kabbalistic interpretation, these sixty warriors may represent divine forces that protect the vulnerable soul.

[2] This profound verse from Song of Songs gains special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of approaching death. It suggests that divine love matches death's power, offering hope that love transcends mortality and continues beyond the grave.

[3] These hopeful verses from Lamentations would be particularly meaningful to the sick who face each day with uncertainty. The promise of renewed divine mercies each morning offers profound comfort that suffering is temporary and God's compassion is reliable.

[1] The collection concludes with an affirmation of divine blessing from Psalm 3:8, ending on a note

[i] This phrase from Song of Songs 3:8 referring to 'fear in the night' is particularly apt in the context of illness, as nighttime often brings increased anxiety, pain, and fear of death for the sick.

[ii] This rare Hebrew construction from Song of Songs 8:6 combines 'flame' with a divine suffix, literally meaning 'flame of Yah (God).' This suggests that love's power has a divine origin, which in the context of Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes God's passionate commitment to the suffering person.

[iii] This passage from Ruth 3:13 originally describes Boaz's promise to redeem Ruth, but in this prayer context, it becomes God's promise to redeem the suffering person, with morning symbolizing either recovery or peaceful transition to the afterlife.

[iv] This powerful verse from Lamentations 3:23 emphasizes divine mercy renewed each morning, offering particular comfort to the ill who measure their suffering day by day and need reassurance of continuing divine compassion.

אחר כל סדר יאמר[iii] [ii] After each order [one] should say:[A]

לְמַעַן יֵחָלְצוּן יְדִידֶיךָ הוֹשִׁיעָה
יְמִינְךָ וַעֲנֵנִי: מָגִנֵּנוּ רְאֵה אֱלֹהִים
וְהַבֵּט פְּנֵי מְשִׁיחֶךָ: לֹא אָמוּת
כִּי אֶחְיֶה וַאֲסַפֵּר מַעֲשֵׂי יָהּ: יַסֹּר
יִסְּרַנִּי יָהּ וְלַמָּוֶת לֹא נְתָנָנִי:
כִּי אֵין בַּמָּוֶת זִכְרֶךָ בִּשְׁאוֹל
מִי יוֹדֶה לָךְ: הֲיִסָּפֵר בַּקֶּבֶר
חַסְדֶּךָ אֱמוּנָתְךָ בָּאֲבַדּוֹן: הֱיִוָּדַע
בַּחֹשֶׁךְ פִּלְאֶךָ וְצִדְקָתְךָ בְּאֶרֶץ
נְשִׁיָּה:[iv] הֲלַמֵּתִים תַּעֲשֶׂה פֶּלֶא אִם
רְפָאִים יָקוּמוּ יוֹדוּךָ סֶלָה:[v] לֹא
הַמֵּתִים יְהַלְלוּ יָהּ וְלֹא כָּל יֹרְדֵי

That Your beloved ones may be delivered,[1] save with Your right hand, and answer me. Our shield, behold, O God, and look upon the face of Your anointed. I shall not die but live, and recount the works of the LORD. The LORD has surely chastened me, but He has not given me over to death. For in death there is no remembrance of You; in Sheol, who will give You thanks? Shall Your lovingkindness be declared in the grave, or Your faithfulness in the place of destruction?[2] Shall Your wonders be known in the darkness, and Your righteousness in the land of forgetfulness?[3] Will You work wonders for the dead?

[A] Or: "After completing each sequence, one should recite:" — This translation clarifies that 'seder' refers to a liturgical sequence, and that the instruction is to recite specific prayers after completing each one.

of confidence rather than supplication. This creates a spiritual journey from distress to assurance, modeling the transformation sought for the ill person.

[2] The Hebrew word 'יְדִידֶיךָ' (yedidecha) refers to those beloved by God. In this liturgical context of Ma'avar Yabok, it specifically applies to the sick person, positioning them as someone dear to God who deserves divine intervention.

[3] The Hebrew 'אֲבַדּוֹן' (Abaddon) is both a poetic name for the realm of the dead and, in Jewish mystical tradition, the deepest level of the underworld. This term emphasizes the complete separation from divine presence that death was understood to represent.

[1] This translation of 'אֶרֶץ נְשִׁיָּה' captures the concept of death as a realm where memory and con-

[v] Cf. Song of Songs — These passionate verses from Song of Songs are included to invoke divine protection and love during times of illness or distress. They create a sense of intimate divine protection, with imagery of embracing hands, guardians, and the powerful seal of love that is 'as strong as death.' In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses would comfort the sick by reassuring them of God's passionate care even in their vulnerable state. | Cf. Book of Ruth — The inclusion of Boaz's promise to Ruth ('Stay this night...I will redeem you') in this prayer collection suggests that it's being repurposed as a divine promise of redemption. Just as Boaz offered Ruth protection and redemption, God promises to redeem the ill person from their suffering, either through recovery or through a peaceful transition if death approaches. | Cf. Lamentations — These hopeful verses from Lamentations are particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok as they offer reassurance that even in the darkest times of illness, God's compassions are 'new every morning.' For the sick who measure their suffering day by day, this promise of renewed divine mercy with each dawn would provide substantial comfort. | Cf. Psalms — The compiler of Ma'avar Yabok has carefully selected psalm verses that progress from cries for help to expressions of confidence in divine protection. This creates a spiritual journey from distress to trust that models the ideal psychological and spiritual transformation for the ill person or those praying on their behalf.

[i] This is a liturgical instruction that appears after the presentation of specific psalms and verses in each of the eight prayer sequences in the 'Seder' portion of Ma'avar Yabok. It tells the reader what to recite after completing each structured prayer order.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder section — The text is providing instructions for how to conclude each of the eight prayer sequences. These structured prayer orders were designed to be recited in sequence when visiting the sick or attending to the dying.

[iii] The phrase 'אֶרֶץ נְשִׁיָּה' (land of forgetfulness) is a poetic description of the realm of the dead, derived from a root meaning 'to forget.' This portrays death as a state where memory fades, contrasting with the vibrant remembrance and praise possible in life.

[iv] The term 'רְפָאִים' (translated as 'shades' or 'ghosts') carries significant theological weight. It refers to the shadowy existence of the dead in Sheol, emphasizing their powerlessness and inability to participate in divine worship. This theological concept reinforces the argument that recovery from illness serves divine purposes by enabling continued praise.

דּוֹמָה: וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ יָהּ מֵעַתָּה
וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ:[i] מָה בֶּצַע
בְּדָמֵנוּ בְּרִדְתֵּנוּ אֶל שָׁחַת הֲיוֹדְךָ
עָפָר הֲיַגִּיד אֲמִתֶּךָ: כִּי לֹא שְׁאוֹל
תוֹדֶךָּ מָוֶת יְהַלְלֶךָּ לֹא יְשַׂבְּרוּ
יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר אֶל אֲמִתֶּךָ:[iii ii]

Will the shades rise up[1] to praise You? Selah. The dead do not praise the LORD, nor do any who go down into silence.[2] But we will bless the LORD from this time forth and forever. Hallelujah. What profit is there in my blood, when I go down to the pit? Will the dust praise You? Will it declare Your truth? For Sheol cannot thank You; death cannot praise You; those who go down to the pit cannot hope for Your faithfulness.[3]

[iii ii] יאמר ג׳ פעמים [i] רפאני יהוה — One should recite three times: "Heal me, O LORD."[A]

[A] Or: "Recite three times: "Heal me, LORD."" — This more concise translation captures the essential instruction while maintaining the imperative tone. It might be preferred in contexts where brevity is valued, though it loses some of the formal quality of the original translation.

sciousness fade. The prayer uses this imagery to argue that divine attributes cannot be properly acknowledged in such a state of forgetting.

[2] I've translated 'רְפָאִים' as 'shades' to capture the sense of insubstantial, shadowy existence attributed to the dead. Other possible translations include 'ghosts' or 'departed spirits.' The term suggests that while these entities might continue to exist in some form, they lack the capacity for proper worship.

[3] The Hebrew 'יוֹרְדֵי דוּמָה' (yordei dumah) literally means 'those who descend to silence/stillness.' This poetic description of death emphasizes the cessation of speech and praise, which is central to the prayer's argument that God benefits more from keeping the person alive.

[1] The final phrase 'לֹא יְשַׂבְּרוּ יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר אֶל אֲמִתֶּךָ' literally means 'those who go down to the pit cannot hope for Your truth/faithfulness.' I've expanded slightly to clarify the meaning that the dead cannot place their hope in divine faithfulness as the living can.

[i] This collection of verses serves as a concluding prayer for each of the eight liturgical sequences (sedarim) in the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok. These verses are strategically selected from various psalms to create a coherent theological argument for healing based on the premise that the living, not the dead, can praise God.

[ii] This collection of verses forms a chiastic structure, beginning and ending with similar themes about the impossibility of praising God in death, creating a rhetorical frame that emphasizes the central message: only the living can properly serve God through praise and thanksgiving.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 60:5 — This verse begins a collection of biblical quotations specifically chosen for the sick or dying, invoking God's salvation for His beloved ones (the ill person). The use of this verse in Ma'avar Yabok recontextualizes a national prayer for Israel's deliverance into a personal plea for healing. | Cf. Psalm 84:9 — This verse reinforces the prayer for divine protection. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the 'anointed' can be understood as the ill person who requires divine attention and healing. | Cf. Psalm 118:17-18 — These verses express hope for recovery and recognition that illness may serve as divine correction rather than punishment unto death. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that suffering can function as spiritual purification. | Cf. Psalm 6:5-6 — These verses present a theological argument for healing based on the premise that the living, not the dead, can praise God. This reflects a common biblical theme that death ends the opportunity for divine service, used here as motivation for God to heal the ill person. | Cf. Psalm 88:10-13 — These questions continue the theological argument that divine wonders, faithfulness, and righteousness cannot be proclaimed in death. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, these verses function as a persuasive appeal to God that healing the sick person would enable continued divine praise. | Cf. Psalm 115:17-18 — This passage provides the theological resolution—while the dead cannot praise God, the living can and will bless God eternally. In the context of a prayer for healing, this serves as both a plea for life and a promise of continued devotion if healing occurs. | Cf. Psalm 30:9-10 — These verses continue the theme that death prevents divine praise, suggesting that God would gain more from the person's continued life and thanksgiving than from their death. | Cf. Isaiah 38:18-19 — Though not directly quoted, the final verse echoes King Hezekiah's prayer during his illness, which similarly argues that the living, not the dead, can praise God. This connection is significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as Hezekiah's recovery from near-death illness would serve as a hopeful exemplar for the sick person.

רְפָאֵנִי יְיָ וְאֵרָפֵא[iv] הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי
וְאִוָּשֵׁעָה כִּי תְהִלָּתִי אָתָּה: תּוֹצִיאֵנִי
מֵרֶשֶׁת זוּ טָמְנוּ לִי כִּי אַתָּה מָעוּזִּי:
בְּיָדְךָ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי פָּדִיתָה
אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת:[v] יְבָרֵכְךָ יְיָ
וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ: יָאֵר יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ
וִיחֻנֶּךָּ: יִשָּׂא יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם
לְךָ שָׁלוֹם: לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְיָ:
קִוִּיתִי יְיָ לִישׁוּעָתְךָ: יְיָ לִישׁוּעָתְךָ
קִוִּיתִי:[vi] לִפּוּרְקָנְךָ סַבָּרִית יְיָ:
סַבָּרִית יְיָ לִפּוּרְקָנְךָ: יְיָ לִפּוּרְקָנְךָ
סַבָּרִית:[vii] אַתָּה סֵתֶר לִי מִצַּר
תִּצְּרֵנִי רָנֵי פַלֵּט תְּסוֹבְבֵנִי סֶלָה:
מִימִינִי מִיכָאֵל מִשְּׂמֹאלִי גַּבְרִיאֵל
מִלְּפָנַי רְפָאֵל וּמֵאֲחוֹרַי נוֹרִיאֵל

Heal me, O LORD, and I shall be healed; save me, and I shall be saved,[1] for You are my praise. Bring me out from the net that they have hidden for me,[A] for You are my stronghold. Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth. May the LORD bless you and protect you. May the LORD make His face shine upon you and be gracious to you. May the LORD lift up His countenance upon you[2] and grant you peace. For Your salvation I wait, O LORD. I wait, O LORD, for Your salvation. O LORD, for Your salvation I wait. For Your redemption I hope,[3] O LORD. I hope, O LORD, for Your redemption. O LORD, for Your redemption I hope. You are my hiding place; You preserve me from trouble; You

[A]Or: "Rescue me from the trap they have set for me" — This alternative translation uses more contemporary language and captures the metaphorical sense of being trapped by illness or misfortune. It might be preferable in a translation aimed at modern readers seeking immediate comprehension over preserving the exact biblical phrasing.

[2]The Hebrew expresses both a request and a certainty—the prayer asks for divine healing while simultaneously affirming confidence that such healing will occur. This grammatical structure creates a statement of faith within the request itself.

[3]The Priestly Blessing progression moves from physical protection to spiritual illumination to the highest blessing of divine attention and peace. In the context of healing prayers, this creates a comprehensive invocation of divine favor.

[4]The Aramaic word 'סַבָּרִית' (translated as 'I hope') has a stronger connotation than mere hoping—it suggests patient anticipation with certainty, a focused waiting with complete trust that divine salvation will arrive.

[iv]The Hebrew notation 'ג' פעמים׳ (pronounced 'gimel pe'amim') is a common instruction in Jewish liturgical texts meaning 'three times.' The letter ג (gimel) has the numerical value of 3.

[v]This phrase 'Refa'eni Adonai' (Heal me, O LORD) is from Jeremiah 17:14. In Ma'avar Yabok, this instruction appears within the 'Seder' section containing structured prayer sequences for the sick and dying.

[vi]Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This verse from Jeremiah is particularly powerful in Ma'avar Yabok's context as it expresses complete dependence on divine healing rather than human intervention. The threefold repetition intensifies this appeal for divine mercy and strengthens the connection between the sick person and God as the ultimate healer. | Cf. Psalm 30 — This prayer instruction in Ma'avar Yabok connects to a broader tradition of healing prayers in biblical literature, especially in Psalms, where healing is directly attributed to divine intervention. The threefold repetition creates a meditative focus on God's healing power.

[i]This opening line quotes Jeremiah 17:14, a verse that became central to Jewish healing prayers. The Hebrew uses a reflexive form 'I shall be healed' (וְאֵרָפֵא), emphasizing that divine healing activates one's own healing capacity.

[ii]This line from Psalm 31:6 was traditionally recited at bedtime and became associated with the moment of death. According to rabbinic tradition, it should be a person's final utterance, and was reportedly spoken by Rabbi Akiva during his martyrdom.

[iii]This triple repetition of Genesis 49:18 with varied word order follows a kabbalistic pattern where the same verse is recited three times with different arrangements of the words to access different spiritual channels and maximize efficacy.

[iv]This Aramaic translation of 'For Your salvation I wait' follows the same pattern of triple repetition with varied word order. The use of Aramaic (the vernacular language of Jews in the Talmudic period) alongside Hebrew was believed to make prayers more accessible to the heavenly court.

310 וְעַל רֹאשִׁי שְׁכִינַת אֵל:[i] בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בַּיּוֹם. בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בַּלָּיְלָה. בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בְּשָׁכְבֵנוּ. בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בְּקוּמֵנוּ:[ii]

surround me with songs of deliverance.[A] Selah. At my right is Michael, at my left is Gabriel, before me is Raphael, behind me is Nuriel, and above my head is the Divine Presence of God.[B1] Blessed is the LORD by day. Blessed is the LORD by night. Blessed is the LORD when we lie down. Blessed is the LORD when we rise up. 325R

[ii] [i] אחר כך יאמר

After this he shall say 330R

חֲבוֹשׁ שִׁבְרִי מְצוּדָתִי וְנָרִי.[iii] וְסִבְרִי

Bind up my brokenness,[C] my fortress and my

[A] Or: "joyful shouts of salvation" — This alternative better captures the exuberant quality of the Hebrew term 'רְנִי' which suggests ringing cries of joy rather than composed songs. It might be preferable in contexts emphasizing the emotional aspects of divine deliverance.

[B] Or: "Shekhinah of God" — Keeping the Hebrew term 'Shekhinah' preserves the kabbalistic connotations of this specific manifestation of divine presence, which has feminine associations in Jewish mysticism. This might be preferable in scholarly translations or those preserving mystical terminology.

[A] Or: "Bandage my wounds" — This alternative is more concrete and medical in tone, which might better fit the context of prayers for physical healing, though it loses some of the poetic quality of the original translation.

[1] This five-directional protection (four horizontal directions plus above) creates a complete spiritual enclosure around the ill person. The Divine Presence (Shekhinah) above completes the protection, as the four angels are understood as extensions of divine power rather than independent forces.

[i] This protective formula invoking the four archangels appeared in various Jewish mystical texts and became part of the bedtime Shema prayer. Each angel corresponds to a direction and has specific protective functions: Michael (right/south/water) represents mercy; Gabriel (left/north/fire) represents strength; Raphael (front/east/air) represents healing; Nuriel (back/west/earth) represents divine light.

[ii] Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This verse begins the healing prayer with a recognition that true healing comes only from God. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this establishes divine healing as the foundation for prayers for the sick. | Cf. Psalm 31:5-6 — These verses from Psalm 31 were traditionally associated with deathbed prayers, especially 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit,' which was reportedly recited by Jesus on the cross. Their inclusion in this healing prayer creates a connection between healing prayers and preparation for death. | Cf. Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26) — The inclusion of the Priestly Blessing in this healing prayer invokes divine protection, grace, and peace for the ill person. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this connects the individual's healing to the cosmic channels of divine blessing. | Cf. Genesis 49:18 — This verse from Jacob's deathbed blessing is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as the book's title refers to Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River. The triple repetition of this verse in slightly varied forms emphasizes patient hope in divine salvation. | Cf. Psalm 32:7 — This psalm verse expresses trust in divine protection, describing God as both a hiding place and a source of joyful deliverance, creating a protective spiritual atmosphere around the ill person. | Cf. Angelic prayer formula — This protective angelic formula appears in various Jewish mystical texts and was commonly used as a protective prayer before sleep. In Ma'avar Yabok, it creates a metaphysical shield around the ill person, with each angel corresponding to a different direction and divine attribute. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 60b — This four-fold blessing creates a continuous cycle of divine praise throughout all times and states of consciousness. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves to ensure divine protection throughout the sick person's day, symbolically extending to all phases of their illness.

315 בָּךְ לְחַתֵּל בִּי כְּאֵבִי, יְחִידָתִי לְבַד
לִשְׁמָךְ תְּיַחֵל.[iv] וְהֵן לָךְ אֵל
וְקַוֶּה אֶת לְבָבִי: סוּרוּ מִמֶּנִּי
כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן כִּי שָׁמַע יְיָ קוֹל
בִּכְיִי: נֹדִי סָפַרְתָּה אָתָּה שִׂימָה
320 דִמְעָתִי בְנֹאדֶךָ[v] הֲלֹא בְּסִפְרָתֶךָ:
יְיָ צְבָאוֹת עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי
יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה: יְיָ צְבָאוֹת אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם
בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ יַעֲנֵנוּ
בְיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ: יְהִיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי
325 פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי
וְגֹאֲלִי:[i]

light.[1] My hope is in You to bandage my pain;[A] my soul alone yearns for Your name. Indeed, to You, O God, my heart looks with expectation:[B] Depart from me, all you workers of iniquity, for the LORD has heard the voice of my weeping. You have counted my wanderings; place my tears in Your flask[2]—are they not in Your record? The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge, Selah. O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in You. Save us, O LORD! May the King answer us on the day we call. May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You,[3] O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.

[iv] [iii] עד כאן [ii] סדר א׳

Thus ends the first order.[C]

335R 340R 345R

[B] Or: "to wrap my suffering" — This more literal rendering of 'חתל' as 'wrap' rather than 'bandage' preserves the physical image of binding or swaddling pain, though it's less idiomatic in English.

[C] Or: "Behold, for You, O God, my heart waits" — This alternative is more direct and literal, emphasizing patient waiting rather than expectant looking. It may better capture the Hebrew 'יקוה' which connotes waiting with hope.

[A] Or: "Here concludes the first liturgical sequence." — This alternate translation makes explicit the liturgical nature of the 'seder' being concluded, which might be helpful for readers unfamiliar with Jewish liturgical terminology.

[1] This poetic opening creates ambiguity about whether God is being asked to bind up the speaker's brokenness, or is being addressed as 'my fortress and my light' who binds up brokenness. Both readings are possible in the Hebrew, and this ambiguity is likely intentional.

[2] This powerful metaphor from Psalm 56 envisions God collecting human tears in a container, preserving them as precious. In Jewish mystical thought, these preserved tears become the basis for future consolation and redemption.

[1] This concluding verse from Psalm 19:15 is frequently used to end prayers in Jewish liturgy. In the context of prayers for the sick, it takes on added significance as a plea that one's final communications with God be received favorably.

[iii] This is a liturgical instruction phrase that appears frequently throughout Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. It guides the prayer leader through the structured orders (sedarim) of prayers for the sick and dying, indicating the transition to the next component in the sequence.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This phrase appears frequently in the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok to indicate transitions between different prayer components. It provides liturgical instruction to the person leading prayers for the sick or dying, showing how the structured prayer sequences should flow. | Cf. Traditional Jewish prayer books (siddurim) — This formulaic instructional phrase resembles those found in traditional Jewish prayer books, which often use similar transitional instructions to guide users through complex liturgical sequences. The author is employing a familiar format that would be recognizable to those accustomed to using prayer books.

[v] This opening line uses several metaphors from the Psalms: God as one who 'binds up' wounds (Psalm 147:3), as a 'fortress' (מָצוּדָה in Psalm 18:3), and as 'light' (Psalm 27:1). These are combined into a personal plea for healing.

[i] The term 'יְחִידָתִי' (my unique one) is a biblical term for the soul found in Psalms (22:21, 35:17). This poetic phrase expresses that only the soul yearns for God's name, emphasizing spiritual connection over physical healing.

[ii] The image of God collecting tears in a bottle or flask (נֹאד) comes from Psalm 56:9 and represents divine remembrance of human suffering. This biblical metaphor would be particularly comforting to the ill or dying.

סדר ב

Order Two[1]

אם ירצה לשנות את טעמו
330 בהתחננו לפני קונו ביום ההוא
או ביום אחר למען יופיע עליו
מהודו יתחיל אנא ה׳ הושיעה
נא וגו׳ ככתוב בסדר א׳ בדף
ב״ח ע״א אח״כ יאמר מזמור י״ט
335 או כ׳ או כ״ב או כ״ג ואחר כך
יאמר המלאך הגואל׃ [v]

If he wishes to vary his approach in supplicating before his Creator on that day or another day so that His glory may shine upon him, he should begin with "Please, O LORD, save us," etc., as written in the first order[2] on page 28a. Afterwards, he should recite Psalm 19 or 20 or 22 or 23, and then say "The Angel, the Redeemer."[3] 350R

(תהלים יט) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר
לְדָוִד׃ הַשָּׁמַיִם מְסַפְּרִים

(Psalm 19) For the Chief Musician, a Psalm of David. The heavens declare the glory of God,[4] and the fir- 355R

[2]This is the second of eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok designed for the sick and dying. Each sequence follows a similar structure but offers different psalm options.

[3]The term 'seder' (order) in this context refers to one of eight standardized liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok for praying on behalf of the sick. Each sequence follows a similar structure but varies in content to address different situations or needs.

[4]This is the opening phrase of Genesis 48:16, part of Jacob's blessing to his grandchildren. The full verse continues: 'The Angel who has redeemed me from all evil, bless the lads; let my name be named upon them, and the name of my fathers Abraham and Isaac; and let them grow into a multitude in the midst of the earth.' This prayer was considered particularly effective for healing and protection.

[1]In the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm's opening verses about cosmic

[iii]Cf. Psalms 6:9 — This verse is used to express the sick person's conviction that God has heard their prayers, creating a spiritual boundary against negative forces. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this signals a transition from distress to divine protection during illness. | Cf. Psalms 56:9 — This reference emphasizes the belief that God carefully accounts for every aspect of human suffering, which would be particularly comforting to the sick or dying. It suggests that no pain is meaningless or forgotten by God. | Cf. Psalms 46:8 — This reference provides assurance of divine presence during illness, with the military title 'LORD of hosts' suggesting God's power to protect and defend the sick person against all spiritual and physical threats. | Cf. Psalms 84:13 — This verse reinforces the theme of trust in God during illness, suggesting that even in suffering, one finds blessing through maintaining faith in divine care. | Cf. Psalms 20:10 — This verse functions as a direct petition for healing and divine response, appropriate for someone who is ill and seeking immediate divine intervention. | Cf. Psalms 19:15 — This concluding verse serves as a final request that the entire prayer be accepted by God. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it's particularly significant as it might be among the last prayers a person recites, expressing hope that their final words will find divine acceptance.

[i]This phrase literally means "until here" and is a common rabbinic formula used to mark the end of a textual unit or section.

[ii]This refers to "the first order" (Seder Alef), which is the first of eight structured prayer sequences in this section of Ma'avar Yabok.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok—Seder structure — The phrase 'Thus ends the first order' indicates a clear structural demarcation in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical arrangement. The text organizes prayers for the sick and dying into eight distinct 'sedarim' (orders), each with a standardized structure. This concluding marker helps users of the text navigate between different prayer sequences when caring for the ill. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok—Prayer structure — This marker concludes the first complete liturgical sequence of Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer orders. The author Aaron Berechia organized these prayers methodically to provide clear guidance for those attending the sick. Similar markers would appear at the conclusion of each of the eight orders, helping users navigate this practical manual.

[iv]Cf. The first order (סדר א) — The text is referencing a previously established prayer sequence that begins with 'Ana Hashem hoshiah na' (Please, O LORD, save us), directing the reader to follow that opening formula before continuing with the variations presented here. | Cf. The Angel, the Redeemer (המלאך הגואל) — This biblical verse is used as a protective prayer for the sick.

כְּבוֹד־אֵל[i] וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדָיו מַגִּיד
הָרָקִיעַ: יוֹם לְיוֹם יַבִּיעַ אֹמֶר
וְלַיְלָה לְלַיְלָה יְחַוֶּה־דָּעַת:
אֵין־אֹמֶר וְאֵין דְּבָרִים בְּלִי
נִשְׁמָע קוֹלָם: בְּכָל־הָאָרֶץ יָצָא
קַוָּם[ii] וּבִקְצֵה תֵּבֵל מִלֵּיהֶם לַשֶּׁמֶשׁ
שָׂם־אֹהֶל בָּהֶם: וְהוּא כְּחָתָן יֹצֵא
מֵחֻפָּתוֹ[iii] יָשִׂישׂ כְּגִבּוֹר לָרוּץ אֹרַח:
מִקְצֵה הַשָּׁמַיִם מוֹצָאוֹ וּתְקוּפָתוֹ
עַל־קְצוֹתָם וְאֵין נִסְתָּר מֵחַמָּתוֹ:
תּוֹרַת יְיָ תְּמִימָה מְשִׁיבַת נָפֶשׁ
עֵדוּת יְיָ נֶאֱמָנָה מַחְכִּימַת פֶּתִי:
פִּקּוּדֵי יְיָ יְשָׁרִים מְשַׂמְּחֵי־לֵב מִצְוַת
יְיָ בָּרָה מְאִירַת עֵינָיִם: יִרְאַת יְיָ
טְהוֹרָה עוֹמֶדֶת לָעַד מִשְׁפְּטֵי־יְיָ
אֱמֶת צָדְקוּ יַחְדָּו: הַנֶּחֱמָדִים מִזָּהָב
וּמִפַּז רָב וּמְתוּקִים מִדְּבַשׁ וְנֹפֶת
צוּפִים: גַּם־עַבְדְּךָ נִזְהָר בָּהֶם
בְּשָׁמְרָם עֵקֶב רָב: שְׁגִיאוֹת מִי־יָבִין
מִנִּסְתָּרוֹת נַקֵּנִי: גַּם מִזֵּדִים חֲשֹׂךְ
עַבְדֶּךָ אַל־יִמְשְׁלוּ־בִי אָז אֵיתָם
וְנִקֵּיתִי מִפֶּשַׁע רָב: יִהְיוּ־לְרָצוֹן
אִמְרֵי־פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ
צוּרִי וְגֹאֲלִי:

mament proclaims His handiwork. Day to day utters
speech, and night to night reveals knowledge. There
is no speech and there are no words; their voice is
not heard. Throughout all the earth their line has
gone forth, and their words to the end of the world. 360R
For the sun He has set a tent among them. And
it is like a bridegroom coming out of his chamber;
it rejoices like a mighty man to run its course. Its
rising is from one end of the heavens, and its cir-
cuit reaches to the other end; and nothing is hidden 365R
from its heat. The Torah of the LORD is perfect,
restoring the soul;[1] the testimony of the LORD is
trustworthy, making the simple wise. The precepts
of the LORD are upright, rejoicing the heart; the
commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening 370R
the eyes. The fear of the LORD is pure, enduring
forever; the judgments of the LORD are true, they
are righteous altogether. More desirable than gold,
than much fine gold, and sweeter than honey and the
drippings of honeycombs. Moreover, Your servant is 375R
warned by them; in keeping them there is great re-
ward. Who can discern errors? Cleanse me from
hidden faults.[2] Also from willful sins restrain Your
servant; let them not rule over me. Then I will be
blameless and clear of great transgression. May the 380R
words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart
be acceptable before You, O LORD, my Rock and
my Redeemer.

harmony serve as a reminder that the sufferer's condition exists within a divinely ordered universe. The psalm transitions from natural revelation (heavens/firmament) to revealed Torah, suggesting a progression from general awareness of God to the specific healing power of divine commandments.

[2]The phrase 'meshivat nafesh' (restoring the soul) is particularly significant in the context of prayers for the sick, as it suggests the Torah's capacity to revitalize not just spiritually but physically. Ma'avar Yabok frequently presents scriptural recitation as having healing power.

[1]This verse aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession and spiritual purification during illness. The book presents illness as potentially resulting from unrecognized sins, and this verse's plea for cleansing from 'hidden faults' reflects the ideal spiritual attitude of the sick person seeking both physical and spiritual healing.

The reference to Jacob is particularly significant given the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok,' which references Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok River. This creates a thematic connection between Jacob's transformative experience and the sick person's hope for divine intervention.

[i]The Hebrew uses 'El' (אֵל) rather than the Tetragrammaton here, while later verses use the Tetragrammaton (יְיָ) when referring to Torah and commandments, suggesting a distinction between God's revelation in nature versus Torah.

[ii]The term 'קַוָּם' (kavam/their line) has been interpreted variously as referring to their measuring line, their rule/domain, or their voice/sound. In Ma'avar Yabok's context of healing prayer, this likely emphasizes how divine influence extends throughout all creation.

[iii]The wedding imagery comparing the sun to a bridegroom emerging from his chamber corresponds to kabbalistic concepts of divine unification that appear throughout Ma'avar Yabok. Such imagery would be especially meaningful in a text concerned with the soul's transition.

(תהלים כ) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר
לְדָוִד[ii]: יַעַנְךָ יְיָ בְּיוֹם צָרָה
יְשַׂגֶּבְךָ שֵׁם אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב:
יִשְׁלַח־עֶזְרְךָ מִקֹּדֶשׁ וּמִצִּיּוֹן
יִסְעָדֶךָּ: יִזְכֹּר כָּל־מִנְחֹתֶךָ
וְעוֹלָתְךָ יְדַשְּׁנֶה סֶלָה[iii]: יִתֶּן־לְךָ
כִּלְבָבֶךָ וְכָל־עֲצָתְךָ יְמַלֵּא:
נְרַנְּנָה בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ וּבְשֵׁם־אֱלֹהֵינוּ
נִדְגֹּל[iv] יְמַלֵּא יְיָ כָּל־מִשְׁאֲלוֹתֶיךָ:
עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי הוֹשִׁיעַ יְיָ מְשִׁיחוֹ
יַעֲנֵהוּ מִשְׁמֵי קָדְשׁוֹ בִּגְבוּרוֹת
יֵשַׁע יְמִינוֹ: אֵלֶּה בָרֶכֶב וְאֵלֶּה
בַּסּוּסִים[v] וַאֲנַחְנוּ בְּשֵׁם־יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ
נַזְכִּיר: הֵמָּה כָּרְעוּ וְנָפָלוּ וַאֲנַחְנוּ
קַמְנוּ וַנִּתְעוֹדָד: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ
יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם־קָרְאֵנוּ: [i]

(Psalm 20) For the Chief Musician. A Psalm of David. May the LORD answer you in the day of trouble;[1] may the name of the God of Jacob set you up on high. May He send you help from the sanctuary, and support you from Zion. May He remember all your offerings, and accept your burnt sacrifice. Selah.[A] May He grant you according to your heart's desire, and fulfill all your counsel. We will rejoice in your salvation, and in the name of our God we will set up our banners.[B] May the LORD fulfill all your petitions. Now I know that the LORD saves His anointed; He will answer him from His holy heaven with the saving strength of His right hand. Some trust in chariots, and some in horses, but we will remember the name of the LORD our God. They have bowed down and fallen, but we have risen and stand upright.[C] Save, LORD! May the King answer

[A] Or: "find your burnt offering pleasingly fat. Selah" — This more literal translation preserves the sacrificial imagery of fat as a sign of quality and divine pleasure. In ancient sacrificial practice, the fat portions were considered the choicest parts, so a "fat" sacrifice was particularly pleasing to God.

[B] Or: "We will sing for joy at your victory, and raise our banners in the name of our God" — This translation better captures the public, celebratory nature of both the singing (רנן/ranan specifically means 'joyful singing') and the banner-raising, emphasizing the communal celebration of divine deliverance rather than just internal rejoicing.

[A] Or: "They collapse and fall, but we rise and remain steadfast" — This translation uses present tense to capture the timeless, paradigmatic nature of this contrast, and "steadfast" better conveys

[2] This psalm was likely composed for a king going into battle and later adapted for general liturgical use in times of distress. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it takes on special significance for the sick and dying who are facing their own "day of trouble."

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The psalm's inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences for the sick reflects its themes of divine order in creation and the restorative power of God's Torah. The final verse (19:15) 'May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You' serves as a particularly appropriate prayer for someone facing illness or death, expressing hope that their prayers will be received favorably by God. | Cf. Jewish liturgy — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok connects the sick person's prayers to the familiar liturgical framework of daily prayer, particularly the concluding verse which would be well-known to Jewish worshippers. This creates continuity between regular prayer practice and prayers offered during illness. | Cf. Zohar — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm's inclusion likely invokes kabbalistic interpretations where the cosmic order described in the first half of the psalm corresponds to divine emanations, while the Torah's perfection in the second half represents the spiritual remedy for the sick person—connecting them to divine harmony through sacred text.

[i] The Hebrew term "lamnatzeach" (לַמְנַצֵּחַ) that begins many psalms likely refers to the choirmaster or music director of the Temple, indicating the psalm was meant to be performed liturgically.

[ii] The term "yedashene" (יְדַשְּׁנֶה) literally means "make fat" and refers to accepting a sacrifice as especially pleasing, implying divine approval. "Selah" is a musical notation possibly indicating a pause or musical interlude.

[iii] The Hebrew "nidgol" (נִדְגֹּל) comes from the root meaning "banner" or "flag" and implies a public, celebratory declaration of allegiance. In this context, it suggests publicly proclaiming loyalty to God's name.

[iv] This phrase contrasts reliance on military might (chariots and horses were ancient symbols of military power) with reliance on God, a recurring theme in biblical literature.

us when we call.[1]

(תהלים כב) לַמְנַצֵּחַ עַל־אַיֶּלֶת
380 הַשַּׁחַר מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד: אֵלִי אֵלִי
לָמָּה עֲזַבְתָּנִי רָחוֹק מִישׁוּעָתִי
דִּבְרֵי שַׁאֲגָתִי: אֱלֹהַי אֶקְרָא יוֹמָם
וְלֹא תַעֲנֶה וְלַיְלָה וְלֹא־דֳמִיָּה
לִי: וְאַתָּה קָדוֹשׁ יוֹשֵׁב תְּהִלּוֹת
385 יִשְׂרָאֵל: בְּךָ בָּטְחוּ אֲבֹתֵינוּ בָּטְחוּ
וַתְּפַלְּטֵמוֹ: אֵלֶיךָ זָעֲקוּ וְנִמְלָטוּ
בְּךָ בָטְחוּ וְלֹא־בוֹשׁוּ: וְאָנֹכִי
תוֹלַעַת וְלֹא־אִישׁ חֶרְפַּת אָדָם
וּבְזוּי עָם: כָּל־רֹאַי יַלְעִגוּ לִי
390 יַפְטִירוּ בְשָׂפָה יָנִיעוּ רֹאשׁ: גֹּל
אֶל־יְיָ יְפַלְּטֵהוּ יַצִּילֵהוּ כִּי חָפֵץ
בּוֹ: כִּי־אַתָּה גֹחִי מִבֶּטֶן מַבְטִיחִי
עַל־שְׁדֵי אִמִּי: עָלֶיךָ הָשְׁלַכְתִּי
מֵרֶחֶם מִבֶּטֶן אִמִּי אֵלִי אָתָּה:
395 אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי כִּי־צָרָה קְרוֹבָה
כִּי־אֵין עוֹזֵר: סְבָבוּנִי פָּרִים רַבִּים
אַבִּירֵי בָשָׁן כִּתְּרוּנִי: פָּצוּ עָלַי
פִּיהֶם אַרְיֵה טֹרֵף וְשֹׁאֵג: כַּמַּיִם
נִשְׁפַּכְתִּי וְהִתְפָּרְדוּ כָּל־עַצְמוֹתָי
400 הָיָה לִבִּי כַּדּוֹנָג נָמֵס בְּתוֹךְ מֵעָי:
יָבֵשׁ כַּחֶרֶשׂ כֹּחִי וּלְשׁוֹנִי מְדֻבָּק
מַלְקוֹחָי וְלַעֲפַר־מָוֶת תִּשְׁפְּתֵנִי:
כִּי סְבָבוּנִי כְּלָבִים עֲדַת מְרֵעִים
חֲקָיפוּנִי כָּאֲרִי יָדַי וְרַגְלָי: אֲסַפֵּר
405 כָּל־עַצְמוֹתָי הֵמָּה יַבִּיטוּ יִרְאוּ־בִי:
יְחַלְּקוּ בְגָדַי לָהֶם וְעַל־לְבוּשִׁי

(Psalm 22) For the conductor, on the ayelet hashachar, a psalm of David. My God, my God, why have You forsaken me? Why are You so far from my salvation and from the words of my 405R anguished roar? My God, I call out by day but You do not answer, and at night there is no silence for me. Yet You are holy, enthroned upon the praises of Israel.[2] In You our fathers trusted; they trusted and You delivered them. To You they cried out and 410R were rescued; in You they trusted and were not put to shame. But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by people. All who see me mock me; they open their lips wide, they shake their head: "Let him commit himself to the LORD; 415R let Him rescue him, let Him deliver him, for He delights in him." For You drew me from the womb, made me secure upon my mother's breasts. Upon You I was cast from birth; from my mother's womb You have been my God. Do not be distant from 420R me, for trouble is near and there is none to help. Many bulls surround me; the mighty ones of Bashan encircle me. They open their mouths against me like a tearing, roaring lion. Like water I am poured out, and all my bones are disjointed; my heart has 425R become like wax, melting within my innards. My strength is dried up like baked clay, and my tongue cleaves to my palate; You lay me in the dust of death.[3] For dogs surround me; a pack of evildoers

the Hebrew nitodad (נִתְעוֹדָד) which implies not just standing but being firmly established or strengthened.

[1]The psalm concludes with a collective prayer ("us") rather than the individual address ("you") of the opening, emphasizing how individual suffering is embraced by communal prayer. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper communal presence during illness and at the moment of death.

[2]This poetic expression suggests that God's presence is manifest through Israel's prayers and worship, a concept particularly resonant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok where proper prayers are seen as creating divine channels between realms.

[3]This powerful metaphor for mortality appears in a psalm that Ma'avar Yabok recommends for recitation by or for the seriously ill. The imagery of physical deterioration and divine abandonment would have particular resonance for those facing death.

[v]Cf. Psalm 91 — Both psalms emphasize divine protection in times of trouble, though Psalm 20 focuses more on communal support while Psalm 91 addresses individual divine protection. | Cf. The Shema prayer — This psalm follows the classic Jewish prayer structure of praise followed by petition, making it particularly suitable for inclusion in standardized prayer sequences for the sick. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This psalm's inclusion in the 'Seder' prayer sequences suggests it was considered to have special healing properties when recited properly, possibly related to its themes of divine support in times of trouble.

יַפִּילוּ גוֹרָל: וְאַתָּה יְיָ אַל־תִּרְחָק
אֱיָלוּתִי לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה: הַצִּילָה
מֵחֶרֶב נַפְשִׁי מִיַּד־כֶּלֶב יְחִידָתִי:
הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי מִפִּי אַרְיֵה וּמִקַּרְנֵי רֵמִים
עֲנִיתָנִי: אֲסַפְּרָה שִׁמְךָ לְאֶחָי
בְּתוֹךְ קָהָל אֲהַלְלֶךָּ: יִרְאֵי יְיָ
הַלְלוּהוּ כָּל־זֶרַע יַעֲקֹב כַּבְּדוּהוּ
וְגוּרוּ מִמֶּנּוּ כָּל־זֶרַע יִשְׂרָאֵל:
כִּי לֹא־בָזָה וְלֹא שִׁקַּץ עֱנוּת עָנִי
וְלֹא־הִסְתִּיר פָּנָיו מִמֶּנּוּ וּבְשַׁוְּעוֹ
אֵלָיו שָׁמָע: מֵאִתְּךָ תְּהִלָּתִי בְּקָהָל
רָב נְדָרַי אֲשַׁלֵּם נֶגֶד יְרֵאָיו: יֹאכְלוּ
עֲנָוִים וְיִשְׂבָּעוּ יְהַלְלוּ יְיָ דֹּרְשָׁיו
יְחִי לְבַבְכֶם לָעַד: יִזְכְּרוּ וְיָשֻׁבוּ
אֶל־יְיָ כָּל־אַפְסֵי־אָרֶץ וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ
לְפָנֶיךָ כָּל־מִשְׁפְּחוֹת גּוֹיִם: כִּי
לַיהוָה הַמְּלוּכָה וּמֹשֵׁל בַּגּוֹיִם:
אָכְלוּ וַיִּשְׁתַּחֲווּ כָּל־דִּשְׁנֵי־אֶרֶץ
לְפָנָיו יִכְרְעוּ כָּל־יוֹרְדֵי עָפָר
וְנַפְשׁוֹ לֹא חִיָּה: זֶרַע יַעַבְדֶנּוּ
יְסֻפַּר לַאדֹנָי לַדּוֹר: יָבֹאוּ וְיַגִּידוּ
צִדְקָתוֹ לְעַם נוֹלָד כִּי עָשָׂה: [i]

encompasses me; like a lion, they are at my hands and my feet. I can count all my bones; they look on and gaze at me. They divide my garments among themselves, and for my clothing they cast lots. But You, O LORD, be not distant; my Strength, hasten to my aid. Deliver my soul from the sword, my only one from the grip of the dog. Save me from the lion's mouth, and from the horns of wild oxen—You have answered me. I will proclaim Your name to my brethren; in the midst of the congregation I will praise You. You who fear the LORD, praise Him; all you descendants of Jacob, honor Him, and stand in awe of Him, all you descendants of Israel. For He has not despised nor abhorred the suffering of the afflicted, nor has He hidden His face from him; but when he cried out to Him, He heard. From You comes my praise in the great congregation; I will fulfill my vows before those who fear Him.[1] The humble shall eat and be satisfied; those who seek Him will praise the LORD. May your hearts live forever! All the ends of the earth shall remember and return to the LORD, and all the families of nations shall bow down before You. For kingship belongs to the LORD, and He rules over the nations. All the robust of the earth shall eat and prostrate themselves; before Him shall bow all who descend to the dust, and he whose soul cannot be kept alive. Offspring shall serve Him; it shall be told of the Lord to the coming generation. They shall come and declare His righteousness to a people yet to be born, for He has done it.

(תהלים כג) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד[ii] יְיָ
רֹעִי לֹא אֶחְסָר: בִּנְאוֹת דֶּשֶׁא

(Psalm 23) A psalm of David. The LORD is my shepherd;[2] I shall not want. He makes me lie down

[1] The theme of fulfilling vows connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper confession and spiritual preparation before death, including the resolution of unfulfilled religious commitments.

[2] This psalm employs the metaphor of God as a shepherd, a powerful image in Jewish tradition that portrays divine care and guidance. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this pastoral imagery would be understood as especially comforting to the ill or dying, suggesting divine guidance through the transition between life and death.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder section — The inclusion of Psalm 22 in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences is significant due to its powerful expressions of both abandonment and ultimate divine rescue. For the seriously ill, this psalm provides a spiritual vocabulary that acknowledges profound suffering while maintaining faith in divine salvation. | Cf. Zohar — This psalm's vivid descriptions of physical and spiritual suffering align with Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework where suffering is understood as a process of spiritual refinement rather than mere punishment.

[ii] This superscription attributes the psalm to King David, who was himself a shepherd before becoming king. This biographical connection adds depth to the pastoral imagery used throughout the psalm.

יַרְבִּיצֵנִי עַל־מֵי מְנֻחוֹת יְנַהֲלֵנִי׃
נַפְשִׁי יְשׁוֹבֵב יַנְחֵנִי בְמַעְגְּלֵי־צֶדֶק
לְמַעַן שְׁמוֹ׃ גַּם כִּי־אֵלֵךְ בְּגֵיא
צַלְמָוֶת [i] לֹא־אִירָא רָע כִּי־אַתָּה
עִמָּדִי שִׁבְטְךָ וּמִשְׁעַנְתֶּךָ הֵמָּה
יְנַחֲמֻנִי׃ תַּעֲרֹךְ לְפָנַי שֻׁלְחָן נֶגֶד
צֹרְרָי דִּשַּׁנְתָּ בַשֶּׁמֶן רֹאשִׁי כּוֹסִי
רְוָיָה׃ אַךְ טוֹב וָחֶסֶד יִרְדְּפוּנִי
כָּל־יְמֵי חַיָּי וְשַׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית־יְיָ
לְאֹרֶךְ יָמִים׃ [ii]

in green pastures; He leads me beside still waters. He restores my soul; He guides me in paths of righteousness for His name's sake. Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death,[1] I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me. You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; You have anointed my head with oil; my cup overflows. Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life, and I shall dwell in the house of the LORD forever.[A]

(תורה) [iv] הַמַּלְאָךְ [v] הַגֹּאֵל אֹתִי
מִכָּל רָע יְבָרֵךְ אֶת הַנְּעָרִים וְיִקָּרֵא
בָהֶם שְׁמִי וְשֵׁם אֲבֹתַי אַבְרָהָם
וְיִצְחָק וְיִדְגּוּ [vi] לָרֹב בְּקֶרֶב הָאָרֶץ׃
וַיִּשְׁמַע אֱלֹהִים אֶת קוֹל הַנַּעַר

(Torah) May the angel who has redeemed me from all harm bless the lads, and may my name be declared upon them, and the name of my fathers Abraham and Isaac, and may they proliferate abundantly like fish within the land.[2] And God heard the voice of

[A] Or: "and I shall return to the house of the LORD for length of days" — The Hebrew verb 'veshavti' carries a dual meaning of both 'dwelling' and 'returning,' and 'le'orekh yamim' literally means 'for length of days' rather than 'forever.' This alternate translation preserves both the sense of returning to a spiritual home and the extended but not necessarily infinite timeframe suggested by the Hebrew phrase.

[1] This famous phrase represents the darkest moments of human experience, including severe illness and the approach of death. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse would be particularly significant as it directly addresses the book's central concern—providing comfort and guidance for those traversing this 'valley' either literally (the dying) or figuratively (the seriously ill).

[2] The Hebrew phrase וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב employs an unusual verb form derived from the word for 'fish' (דג), creating a vivid image of multiplication and abundance like fish spawning. This blessing for proliferation would resonate powerfully in a context of illness where life itself might be threatened.

[i] The Hebrew phrase 'gei tzalmavet' (valley of the shadow of death) is a powerful metaphor that appears in Ma'avar Yabok as particularly relevant for those who are ill or dying. In the context of this book, this phrase takes on heightened significance as it directly addresses the journey through mortality that the entire work is concerned with.

[ii] The Hebrew verb 'veshavti' can be translated as 'I shall dwell' but also carries connotations of 'returning' or 'sitting,' suggesting both permanent residence and a homecoming. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this final verse would be interpreted as referring to the soul's eternal dwelling in the divine presence after death.

[iii] Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok's inclusion of this psalm in its liturgical sequences for the sick and dying draws on the Zoharic interpretation that sees the entire psalm as a metaphor for the soul's journey through death to eternal divine presence. This kabbalistic reading reinforces the book's purpose of providing spiritual comfort during the transition between worlds. | Cf. Berakhot — By including Psalm 23 in its prayer sequences for the sick and dying, Ma'avar Yabok follows a long-standing Jewish tradition referenced in the Talmud of using this psalm for comfort during times of transition between life and death. This reinforces the book's grounding in traditional Jewish approaches to death and mourning.

[iv] This indicates that the verses come from the Torah (Pentateuch), which was standard practice in prayer compilations to identify the scriptural source. Ma'avar Yabok organizes biblical verses by their source (Torah, Prophets, Writings) to create a comprehensive spiritual framework for healing prayers.

[v] The phrase 'the angel who redeems' is significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it connects to the book's focus on spiritual protection during transitions. In Jewish mystical tradition, angels serve as guides for the soul during critical moments of transition, including illness and death.

[vi] This unusual phrase means 'may they multiply like fish,' employing a verb derived from the noun 'fish' (דג). Fish were seen as symbols of fertility and blessing since they multiply abundantly and are protected by water from the evil eye.

וַיִּקְרָא מַלְאַךְ אֱלֹהִים אֶל הָגָר מִן
הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיֹּאמֶר לָהּ מַה לָּךְ הָגָר
אַל תִּירְאִי כִּי שָׁמַע אֱלֹהִים אֶל
קוֹל הַנַּעַר בַּאֲשֶׁר הוּא שָׁם: אַל
תְּשַׁלַּח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנַּעַר וְאַל תַּעַשׂ
לוֹ מְאוּמָה כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי
יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים אַתָּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ אֶת
בִּנְךָ אֶת יְחִידְךָ מִמֶּנִּי: קוּמִי שְׂאִי
אֶת הַנַּעַר וְהַחֲזִיקִי אֶת יָדֵךְ בּוֹ
כִּי לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל אֲשִׂימֶנּוּ: כִּי בָרֵךְ
אֲבָרֶכְךָ וְהַרְבָּה אַרְבֶּה אֶת זַרְעֲךָ
כְּכוֹכְבֵי הַשָּׁמַיִם וְכַחוֹל אֲשֶׁר עַל
שְׂפַת הַיָּם וְיִרַשׁ זַרְעֲךָ אֵת שַׁעַר
אֹיְבָיו: וְהִתְבָּרֲכוּ בְזַרְעֲךָ כֹּל גּוֹיֵי
הָאָרֶץ עֵקֶב אֲשֶׁר שָׁמַעְתָּ בְּקֹלִי: [i]

the lad, and an angel of God called to Hagar from heaven and said to her, "What troubles you, Hagar? Fear not, for God has heard the voice of the lad where he is. Do not stretch out your hand against the lad, nor do anything to him, for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only one, from Me. Arise, lift up the lad and grasp your hand upon him, for I will make him into a great nation. For I will surely bless you and greatly multiply your seed like the stars of heaven and like the sand that is on the seashore, and your seed shall inherit the gate of their enemies. And all the nations of the earth shall be blessed through your seed, because you have listened to My voice."[1]

(נביאים) יְהוָה תִּשְׁפֹּת שָׁלוֹם
לָנוּ[ii] כִּי גַּם כָּל מַעֲשֵׂינוּ פָּעַלְתָּ
לָנוּ: יְהוָה בַּצַּר פָּקָדוּךָ צָקוֹן לַחַשׁ
מוּסָרְךָ לָמוֹ:[iii] אַף אֹרַח מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ
יְהוָה קִוִּינוּךָ לְשִׁמְךָ וּלְזִכְרְךָ
תַּאֲוַת נָפֶשׁ: שִׁוִּיתִי עַד בֹּקֶר כָּאֲרִי
כֵּן יְשַׁבֵּר כָּל עַצְמוֹתָי[iv] מִיּוֹם עַד
לַיְלָה תַּשְׁלִימֵנִי: אֲדֹנָי עֲלֵיהֶם יְחִיוּ
וּלְכָל בָּהֶן חַיֵּי רוּחִי וְתַחֲלִימֵנִי

O LORD, You will establish peace for us, for You have also performed all our works for us. O LORD, in distress they sought You; they poured out a whispered prayer when Your chastening was upon them. Indeed, in the path of Your judgments, O LORD, we have waited for You; for Your name and for Your remembrance is the desire of our soul. I have set myself until morning; like a lion, so He breaks all my bones;[2] from day until night You make an end of me.

[1] These verses combine excerpts from three biblical narratives: Jacob blessing his grandsons (Genesis 48), Hagar and Ishmael in the wilderness (Genesis 21), and the binding of Isaac (Genesis 22). All three involve divine intervention averting death, making them powerful texts for healing prayers. Their arrangement creates a progression from individual blessing to national covenant, emphasizing both personal salvation and collective hope.

[2] This vivid metaphor from Hezekiah's prayer describes the intensity of physical suffering during serious illness. While shocking in its imagery, it authentically captures the experience of severe physical pain while acknowledging God's sovereignty even in suffering.

[i] Cf. Genesis 48:16 — This opening verse is drawn from Jacob's deathbed blessing to his grandsons. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a powerful protective invocation, calling upon the same angelic protection that watched over Jacob to now guard the sick person. This connects the current suffering to ancestral protection and divine promises. | Cf. Genesis 21:17-18 — The verses about Hagar and Ishmael depict divine intervention at a moment of mortal danger. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they serve as a powerful reminder that God hears the cries of those in distress and can provide salvation even in seemingly hopeless situations. The passage reassures the ill person that God is attentive to their suffering. | Cf. Genesis 22:12, 16-18 — These verses invoke God's promise to Abraham after the Akedah (binding of Isaac), a moment when death was averted through divine intervention. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves both as a plea for similar intervention for the sick person and as a reminder of the covenant relationship between God and the Jewish people that transcends individual mortality.

[ii] This opening verse uses the unusual verb "tishpot" (תִּשְׁפֹּת) for establishing peace, which shares a root with "shofet" (judge). This creates a wordplay suggesting that God's judgment ultimately results in peace, an important theological concept in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to suffering.

[iii] The Hebrew phrase "tzakun lachash" (צָקוֹן לַחַשׁ) describes a whispered or silent prayer, literally "they poured out a whisper." This evokes the quiet, intimate prayers often offered at a sickbed.

[iv] This powerful metaphor comparing God to a lion breaking bones expresses the overwhelming physical pain of serious illness. In Hezekiah's original context, this refers to his near-fatal illness from which God eventually healed him.

וְהַחֲיֵנִי: כִּי לֹא שְׁאוֹל תּוֹדֶךָּ מָוֶת
יְהַלְלֶךָּ[i] לֹא יְשַׂבְּרוּ יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר
אֶל אֲמִתֶּךָ: חַי חַי הוּא יוֹדֶךָ
כָּמוֹנִי הַיּוֹם אָב לְבָנִים יוֹדִיעַ אֶל
אֲמִתֶּךָ:[ii] יְהוָה לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי וּנְגִנוֹתַי
נְנַגֵּן כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּינוּ עַל בֵּית יְהוָה:
חַזְקוּ יָדַיִם רָפוֹת וּבִרְכַּיִם כֹּשְׁלוֹת
אַמְּצוּ: יְהוָה חָנֵּנוּ לְךָ קִוִּינוּ הֱיֵה
זְרֹעָם לַבְּקָרִים אַף יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ בְּעֵת
צָרָה: נֹתֵן לַיָּעֵף כֹּחַ וּלְאֵין אוֹנִים
עָצְמָה יַרְבֶּה: וְקוֵי יְהוָה יַחֲלִיפוּ
כֹחַ יַעֲלוּ אֵבֶר כַּנְּשָׁרִים[iii] יָרוּצוּ
וְלֹא יִיגְעוּ יֵלְכוּ וְלֹא יִיעָפוּ: [iv]

Lord, by these things men live, and in all these is the life of my spirit; so You will restore me and revive me. For the grave cannot thank You, death cannot praise You;[1] those who go down to the pit cannot hope for Your truth. The living, the living, he shall praise You, as I do this day; the father shall make known Your truth to the children.[2] The LORD is ready to save me; therefore we will play my songs on stringed instruments[3] all the days of our life in the house of the LORD. Strengthen the weak hands, and make firm the feeble knees. O LORD, be gracious to us; we have waited for You. Be their arm every morning, our salvation also in the time of trouble. He gives power to the weak, and to those who have no might He increases strength. But those who wait on the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles,[4] they shall run and not be weary, they shall walk and not faint.

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(כתובים[i]) וַיהִי יְהוָה מִשְׂגָּב לַדָּךְ

(From Writings) The LORD will be a refuge for the

[1]This theological statement reflects the biblical view that death ends one's ability to actively praise God, which serves as an argument for healing and life extension. This contrasts with later Jewish mystical views (including elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok) that describe the soul's continued spiritual activity after death.

[2]This reference to intergenerational religious instruction connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper preparation for death, which includes ensuring religious traditions are transmitted to future generations.

[3]Hezekiah's commitment to ongoing worship after his healing exemplifies the ideal response to divine deliverance—continued dedication to religious practice. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the hope for recovery and renewed spiritual devotion.

[1]This famous image of spiritual renewal has profound relevance in Ma'avar Yabok's context, suggesting that even when physical healing doesn't occur, spiritual elevation remains possible through proper religious orientation toward suffering and death.

[i]The theological assertion that the dead cannot praise God is a recurring theme in Ma'avar Yabok. This biblical view is used to argue that healing allows continued divine service, though the book also incorporates later Jewish concepts of the soul's continued existence and activity after death.

[ii]This reference to fathers teaching children about God's faithfulness reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation for death, including passing on religious traditions to the next generation.

[iii]The Hebrew "ever" (אֵבֶר) refers specifically to the pinion or strong outer wing feathers of eagles. This metaphor of ascending like eagles has become one of the most beloved images of spiritual and physical renewal in biblical tradition.

[iv]Cf. Isaiah 26:12-13 — These verses appear in Isaiah's prayer for deliverance and express trust that God is ultimately the author of all human accomplishments. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses serve as a reminder that even in illness, one should recognize God's hand in all things. | Cf. Isaiah 38:9-20 — Many of these verses come from King Hezekiah's prayer after his recovery from a life-threatening illness. This is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok as Hezekiah's experience represents the ideal model of illness, repentance, prayer, and divine healing. | Cf. Isaiah 35:3-4 — This verse about strengthening weak hands and feeble knees appears in a section of Isaiah that promises divine deliverance and healing. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as both a prayer for the sick person's recovery and an exhortation to caregivers to provide strength and support. | Cf. Isaiah 40:29-31 — These final verses about God giving strength to the weary are among the most beloved in Isaiah. In Ma'avar Yabok, they provide spiritual comfort by promising

מִשֹּׂנְאָי כִּי אֲמִצֵּנִי: חָנֵּנִי יְהוָה כִּי
רָאֵה עָנְיִי מִשֹּׂנְאָי מְרוֹמְמִי מִשַּׁעֲרֵי
מָוֶת[ii]: לְמַעַן אֲסַפְּרָה כָּל תְּהִלָּתֶיךָ
בְּשַׁעֲרֵי בַת צִיּוֹן אָגִילָה בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ:
יְהוָה אֲדֹנֵינוּ מָה אַדִּיר שִׁמְךָ בְּכָל
הָאָרֶץ: תַּאֲוַת עֲנָוִים שָׁמַעְתָּ יְהוָה
תָּכִין לִבָּם תַּקְשִׁיב אָזְנֶךָ: אוֹדֶה
יְהוָה בְּכָל לִבִּי אֲסַפְּרָה כָּל נִפְלְאוֹתֶיךָ:
אֶשְׂמְחָה וְאֶעְלְצָה בָךְ אֲזַמְּרָה שִׁמְךָ
עֶלְיוֹן: כִּי אַתָּה תָּאִיר נֵרִי[iv] יְהוָה
אֱלֹהַי יַגִּיהַּ חָשְׁכִּי: כִּי בְךָ אָרֻץ
גְּדוּד וּבֵאלֹהַי אֲדַלֶּג שׁוּר: וַתְּחַן

oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble. Be gracious to me, O LORD; see my affliction from those who hate me, You who lift me up from the gates of death,[1] so that I may recount all Your praises in the gates of the daughter of Zion and rejoice in Your salvation. O LORD, our Lord, how majestic is Your name in all the earth! You have heard the desire of the humble, O LORD; You will strengthen their heart, You will incline Your ear. I will praise the LORD according to His righteousness, and I will sing praise to the name of the LORD Most High. From the mouths of infants and nursing babies You have established strength because of Your adversaries, to silence the enemy and the avenger. Lest he tear my soul like a lion, rending it in pieces, with none to deliver. The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer, my God, my rock in whom I take refuge, my shield and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold. I call upon the LORD, who is worthy of praise, and I am saved from my enemies. The cords of death encompassed me, and the torrents of destruction terrified me. The cords of Sheol surrounded me;[2] the snares of death confronted me. In my distress I called upon the LORD, and to my God I cried for help. He heard my voice from His temple, and my cry before Him came to His ears. I will praise

[2]This verse expresses the hope for divine rescue from the brink of death, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok's prayers for the sick. The Hebrew uses the metaphor of physical elevation (meromemi) from the gates of death, suggesting both physical healing and spiritual elevation.

[3]The repeated imagery of 'cords' (chevlei) creates a parallel between death, destruction, and Sheol (the underworld). This triple parallel emphasizes the comprehensive nature of the threat facing the ill person, who feels encircled by mortality from all sides.

divine empowerment even when physical strength fails, and suggest that waiting on God (prayer and faith) leads to spiritual renewal. | Cf. The Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok draws extensively on the Zohar in its understanding of illness and healing. The selection of these particular prophetic verses aligns with the Zoharic view that suffering can lead to spiritual elevation when approached with proper intention and prayer.

[v]This Hebrew heading identifies that what follows are verses from the Ketuvim (Writings), the third section of the Hebrew Bible. In Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical system, verses are organized by their scriptural source: Torah, Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings).

[i]The metaphor of the 'gates of death' (sha'arei mavet) appears throughout biblical literature, depicting death as a realm with entrances that one approaches in severe illness. This imagery would be particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the critically ill who are seen as approaching these gates but hoping for divine rescue.

[ii]The Hebrew phrase 'chevlei mavet' (cords of death) is a powerful metaphor that appears in several psalms, depicting death as an entangling force that binds its victims. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this image resonates with the experience of the seriously ill, who may feel ensnared by their condition.

[iii]The image of God lighting one's lamp has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok, which elsewhere explores the kabbalistic significance of light and lamps, particularly connecting them to the divine name and the human soul.

510 לִי מָגֵן יִשְׁעֶךָ וִימִינְךָ תִסְעָדֵנִי וְעַנְוָתְךָ תַרְבֵּנִי: כִּי אֹרֶךְ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם יוֹסִיפוּ לָךְ: [i]

the LORD with my whole heart; I will tell of all Your wonderful deeds. I will be glad and rejoice in You; I will sing praise to Your name, O Most High. For You light my lamp; the LORD my God illuminates my darkness. For by You I can run against a troop, 550R and by my God I can leap over a wall. You have given me the shield of Your salvation; Your right hand supports me, and Your gentleness makes me great.[1] For length of days and years of life and peace they will add to you.[2] 555R

ואח״כ יאמר[ii] למען יחלצון ידידיך וגו׳[iii] רפאני ה׳ וגו׳[iv] כל הכתוב למעלה[v] עד צורי וגואלי׳ [i ii]

After this, recite “That Your beloved ones may be delivered”[3] etc., “Heal me, O LORD”[4] etc., and all that is written above until “my Rock and my Redeemer.”[5]

[1]The Hebrew word translated as ‘gentleness’ (anvatecha) can also mean ‘Your humility’ or ‘Your condescension,’ suggesting God’s willingness to lower Himself to assist humans. This creates a beautiful paradox where divine humility leads to human exaltation.

[2]This concluding verse from Proverbs serves as a powerful benediction for the sick person, promising the very things that illness threatens to take away: longevity, vitality, and wellbeing. Its inclusion transforms the entire prayer sequence from lamentation to blessing.

[3]This is the opening of Psalm 60:7/108:7. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this verse takes on special significance as a prayer for the deliverance of the sick person from their suffering.

[4]This phrase from Jeremiah 17:14 is particularly appropriate in a healing prayer sequence. The full verse continues ‘and I shall be healed; save me, and I shall be saved, for You are my praise.’

[1]These words (צורי וגואלי) conclude Psalm 19:15 and are used here to mark the endpoint of a prayer sequence. This common closing formula connects the person praying to divine strength and redemption.

[i]Cf. Book of Psalms — These psalm verses have been carefully selected and arranged for their themes of divine protection, deliverance from death, and thanksgiving for salvation. In Ma’avar Yabok, they serve as powerful prayers for the sick, connecting individual suffering with biblical expressions of distress and divine rescue. | Cf. Proverbs 3:2 — The compilation concludes with a promise from Proverbs about longevity, which is particularly meaningful in the context of prayers for healing the sick. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok structure — This compilation of verses is part of the ‘Seder’ section of Ma’avar Yabok, specifically within the collection of verses from Writings (Ketuvim) that follows psalms in the liturgical sequence. These verses are arranged to create a cohesive prayer emphasizing themes of divine deliverance from death and thanksgiving for salvation. | Cf. Jewish tradition of biblical verse compilation — This passage exemplifies the Jewish practice of likkutei pesukim (compiled verses), where biblical verses are selected and arranged to form new liturgical prayers. Ma’avar Yabok employs this technique extensively, using verses that specifically address healing, divine protection, and salvation from death.

[ii]This is a liturgical instruction indicating the next step in the prayer sequence. ‘ואח״כ’ (ve-achar kach) means ‘and after this’ or ‘afterward,’ while ‘יאמר’ (yomar) means ‘he shall say’ or ‘one should recite.’

[iii]This is the beginning of a verse from Psalm 60:7/108:7 that means ‘That Your beloved ones may be delivered.’ The ‘וגו” (ve-gomer) is an abbreviation for ‘וגומר’ meaning ‘et cetera’ or ‘and so on,’ indicating that the reader should continue with the rest of this well-known verse.

[iv]This is the beginning of a verse from Jeremiah 17:14 that means ‘Heal me, O LORD.’ Again, ‘וגו” indicates that the reader should continue with the full verse.

[v]This phrase means ‘all that is written above,’ directing the reader to repeat text that appeared earlier in the prayer sequence.

[iii]סדר ג

Order Three[A] 560R

יתחיל אנא ה׳ הושיעה נא וגו׳ ככתוב בסדר א׳ למעלה[iv] אחר כך יאמר כ״ד או נ״ה או כ״ח או ל׳ [v] ואח״כ יאמר עזי וזמרת יה.[vii vi]

He shall begin with "Please, O LORD, save us, etc." as written above in the first order,[B] after which he shall recite Psalm 24 or 25 or 28 or 30,[C] and afterward he shall say "My strength and song is the LORD."[1] 565R

לְדָוִד מִזְמוֹר[i] (תהלים כד) לַיְיָ

(Psalm 24) Of David. A Psalm. The earth is the

[A]Or: "Third Sequence" — The term 'seder' in this context refers to a liturgical sequence or arrangement. While 'Order 3' is more literal and maintains consistency with the numbering system, 'Third Sequence' might better convey to modern readers that this is part of a series of structured prayer arrangements designed for specific situations.

[B]Or: "One should begin with "Please, O LORD, save us, etc." as written above in the first order" — This alternate uses an impersonal construction rather than a masculine third-person verb form, which might be preferable for a modern translation that aims for gender neutrality in liturgical instructions.

[C]Or: "after which he shall recite either Psalm 24, 25, 28, or 30" — This alternate is slightly more formal in its listing of the psalm options, using 'either' to introduce the list, which might better reflect the formal liturgical context.

[1]This biblical phrase emphasizes God as the source of both strength and joyful praise. In the context of illness, it suggests that divine power provides both the healing itself and the reason for thanksgiving afterward.

[vi]This phrase means 'until "my Rock and my Redeemer"' which are the concluding words of Psalm 19:15. This indicates where to stop when reciting the previously mentioned prayers.

[vii]Cf. Psalm 60:7/108:7 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is repurposed as a healing prayer, asking God to deliver the sick person from their suffering. The biblical context involves God delivering His beloved people, and here it's applied individually to the sick person as one of God's beloved. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This direct plea for healing from Jeremiah is particularly appropriate in the context of prayers for the sick. In Ma'avar Yabok, biblical verses are carefully selected for their healing properties, and this verse explicitly requests both healing and salvation from God. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — These words serve as a standard closing formula in Jewish prayers. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they provide a fitting conclusion to prayers for the sick by connecting the sufferer to divine strength (Rock) and redemption, whether through healing or through a peaceful transition in death.

[i]This heading marks the third of eight structured prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok designed for healing the sick and comforting the dying. Like the other seven sequences, it follows a standardized structure while offering different psalm options.

[ii]This refers to the standardized opening prayer that begins each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section. Rather than repeating this lengthy opening each time, the author directs readers back to where it first appears.

[iii]These are abbreviated references to psalm numbers using Hebrew letter numerals: כ״ד = 24, כ״ה = 25, כ״ח = 28, ל׳ = 30. The author gives options for different psalms that would be appropriate in this context.

[iv]This phrase "My strength and song is the LORD" comes from the Song at the Sea (Exodus 15:2), recited after Israel's miraculous deliverance at the Red Sea. It represents divine salvation from peril, making it particularly appropriate in prayers for healing.

[v]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder section — This instruction is part of the third liturgical order (Seder Gimel) in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer sequences for the sick and dying. It demonstrates how the author created a systematic framework where each order follows the same opening formula but then offers options for different psalms appropriate to various situations of illness. | Cf. Exodus 15:2 — This biblical phrase from Exodus 15:2 is taken from the triumphant Song at the Sea, making it particularly appropriate in a healing context. It represents divine deliverance from peril and the joy of salvation, offering hope to the ill person while connecting their individual situation to the broader narrative of Israel's redemption.

הָאָרֶץ וּמְלוֹאָהּ תֵּבֵל וְיֹשְׁבֵי בָהּ׃
כִּי הוּא עַל יַמִּים יְסָדָהּ וְעַל נְהָרוֹת יְכוֹנְנָהָ׃ מִי יַעֲלֶה בְהַר יְיָ[ii] וּמִי יָקוּם בִּמְקוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ׃ נְקִי כַפַּיִם וּבַר לֵבָב אֲשֶׁר לֹא נָשָׂא לַשָּׁוְא נַפְשִׁי וְלֹא נִשְׁבַּע לְמִרְמָה׃ יִשָּׂא בְרָכָה מֵאֵת יְיָ וּצְדָקָה מֵאֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעוֹ׃ זֶה דּוֹר דֹּרְשָׁיו מְבַקְשֵׁי פָנֶיךָ יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה׃ שְׂאוּ שְׁעָרִים רָאשֵׁיכֶם וְהִנָּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם[iii] וְיָבוֹא מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד׃ מִי זֶה מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד יְיָ עִזּוּז וְגִבּוֹר יְיָ גִּבּוֹר מִלְחָמָה׃ שְׂאוּ שְׁעָרִים רָאשֵׁיכֶם וּשְׂאוּ פִּתְחֵי עוֹלָם וְיָבֹא מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד׃ מִי הוּא זֶה מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד יְיָ צְבָאוֹת הוּא מֶלֶךְ הַכָּבוֹד סֶלָה׃[iv]

LORD's, and all it contains; the world, and those who dwell in it. For He has founded it upon the seas, and established it upon the rivers. Who shall ascend the mountain of the LORD? And who shall stand in His holy place?[A] One with clean hands and a pure heart,[B] who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood, and has not sworn deceitfully. He shall receive a blessing from the LORD, and righteousness from the God of his salvation. This is the generation of those who seek Him, who seek Your face, O Jacob. Selah.[1] Lift up your heads, O gates, and be lifted up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in. Who is this King of glory? The LORD strong and mighty,[2] the LORD mighty in battle. Lift up your heads, O gates, and lift up, O ancient doors, that the King of glory may come in. Who is He, this King of glory? The LORD of hosts, He is the King of glory. Selah.

לְדָוִד אֵלֶיךָ יְיָ (תהלים כה)

(Psalm 25) Of David. To You, O LORD, I lift up my

[A] Or: "Who may ascend the mountain of the LORD? And who may stand in His holy place?" — The Hebrew verbs could be translated with 'may' rather than 'shall' to better convey the sense of permission or qualification rather than futurity. This alternative emphasizes the psalm's focus on who is worthy to approach the divine presence.

[B] Or: "One with innocent hands and a pure heart" — The Hebrew נְקִי (n'ki) can be rendered as 'innocent' rather than 'clean,' which might better capture the moral dimension implied in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where spiritual purity before death is emphasized.

[1] This musical notation appears twice in this psalm. In the context of prayers for the sick, it might indicate moments of pause for reflection or deeper contemplation on the divine sovereignty that governs both life and death.

[2] The Hebrew term עִזּוּז (izzuz) for 'strong' is an intensive form that emphasizes God's supreme power, particularly relevant for prayers seeking divine intervention in illness.

[vi] While many psalms begin with "A psalm of David" (מזמור לדוד), this one reverses the order to "Of David. A psalm" (לדוד מזמור), which some rabbinic commentators interpret to mean that David was divinely inspired before composing this particular psalm.

[i] This question about who may ascend God's mountain has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as it parallels the book's central concern with who may successfully ascend to higher spiritual realms after death.

[ii] This imagery of gates lifting their heads to admit the King of glory has been interpreted in Jewish mystical tradition as referring to the various celestial gates through which a soul must pass in its ascent after death.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder section — This psalm was selected for the third liturgical order (Seder Gimel) of Ma'avar Yabok as appropriate for the sick and dying because of its themes of divine sovereignty, moral purity, and the hope of ascending to God's holy place. These themes would provide comfort to the ill person by emphasizing the holiness required to approach God and the hope of ultimately standing in the divine presence. | Cf. Zohar — Within the kabbalistic framework of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm would be understood as describing not just who may physically ascend to the Temple in Jerusalem, but which souls may ascend through the spiritual worlds after death. The 'clean hands and pure heart' represent the spiritual purification necessary for the soul's elevation, while the 'King of glory' represents the divine presence the soul encounters in higher realms.

נַפְשִׁי אֶשָּׂא׃[i] אֱלֹהַי בְּךָ בָטַחְתִּי
אַל־אֵבוֹשָׁה אַל־יַעַלְצוּ אוֹיְבַי
לִי׃ גַּם כָּל־קֹוֶיךָ לֹא יֵבֹשׁוּ
545 יֵבֹשׁוּ הַבּוֹגְדִים רֵיקָם׃ דְּרָכֶיךָ
יְיָ הוֹדִיעֵנִי אֹרְחוֹתֶיךָ לַמְּדֵנִי׃
הַדְרִיכֵנִי בַאֲמִתֶּךָ וְלַמְּדֵנִי
כִּי־אַתָּה אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי אוֹתְךָ קִוִּיתִי
כָּל־הַיּוֹם׃ זְכֹר־רַחֲמֶיךָ יְיָ וַחֲסָדֶיךָ
550 כִּי מֵעוֹלָם הֵמָּה׃ חַטֹּאות נְעוּרַי
וּפְשָׁעַי אַל־תִּזְכֹּר[ii] כְּחַסְדְּךָ
זְכָר־לִי־אַתָּה לְמַעַן טוּבְךָ יְיָ׃
טוֹב־וְיָשָׁר יְיָ עַל־כֵּן יוֹרֶה חַטָּאִים
בַּדָּרֶךְ׃ יַדְרֵךְ עֲנָוִים בַּמִּשְׁפָּט
555 וילַמֵּד עֲנָוִים דַּרְכּוֹ׃ כָּל־אָרְחוֹת
יְיָ חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת לְנֹצְרֵי בְרִיתוֹ
וְעֵדֹתָיו׃ לְמַעַן־שִׁמְךָ יְיָ וְסָלַחְתָּ
לַעֲוֹנִי כִּי רַב־הוּא׃ מִי־זֶה הָאִישׁ
יְרֵא יְיָ יוֹרֶנּוּ בְּדֶרֶךְ יִבְחָר׃
560 נַפְשׁוֹ בְּטוּב תָּלִין וְזַרְעוֹ יִירַשׁ
אָרֶץ׃ סוֹד יְיָ לִירֵאָיו[iii] וּבְרִיתוֹ
לְהוֹדִיעָם׃ עֵינַי תָּמִיד אֶל־יְיָ כִּי
הוּא־יוֹצִיא מֵרֶשֶׁת רַגְלָי׃ פְּנֵה־אֵלַי
וְחָנֵּנִי כִּי־יָחִיד וְעָנִי אָנִי׃ צָרוֹת
565 לְבָבִי הִרְחִיבוּ מִמְּצוּקוֹתַי
הוֹצִיאֵנִי׃ רְאֵה עָנְיִי וַעֲמָלִי וְשָׂא
לְכָל־חַטֹּאותָי׃ רְאֵה־אוֹיְבַי כִּי־רָבּוּ

soul.[1] My God, in You I have trusted; let me not be ashamed, let not my enemies exult over me.[2] Indeed, all who wait for You will not be put to shame; those who act treacherously without cause will be put to shame. Make known to me Your ways, O LORD; 590R
teach me Your paths. Lead me in Your truth and teach me, for You are the God of my salvation; for You I wait all day long. Remember Your compassion, O LORD, and Your loving-kindnesses, for they
have been from of old. Do not remember the sins 595R
of my youth or my transgressions; according to Your loving-kindness remember me, for the sake of Your goodness, O LORD. Good and upright is the LORD; therefore He instructs sinners in the way.[3] He guides
the humble in justice, and teaches the humble His 600R
way. All the paths of the LORD are loving-kindness and truth to those who keep His covenant and His testimonies. For the sake of Your name, O LORD, pardon my iniquity, for it is great. Who is the man
who fears the LORD? He will instruct him in the way 605R
he should choose. His soul will abide in prosperity, and his descendants will inherit the land. The secret counsel of the LORD is for those who fear Him,[4] and
His covenant, to make them know it. My eyes are
continually toward the LORD, for He will bring my 610R
feet out of the net.[A] Turn to me and be gracious to

[A] Or: "My eyes are ever toward the LORD, for He will extract my feet from the snare" — This alternate translation emphasizes the imagery of divine rescue from a trap or snare, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's view of illness as a form of spiritual entrapment from which one needs divine extraction.

[1] The Hebrew verb 'essa' literally means 'I will lift/raise' and creates a vivid image of the soul being elevated toward God, resonating with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the soul's journey and elevation.
[2] In Ma'avar Yabok's mystical framework, these 'enemies' would be understood on multiple levels: as human adversaries, as physical illnesses, and as spiritual forces (like the Angel of Death or negative spiritual entities called 'chitzonim' or 'external forces').
[3] This verse reinforces a central theological principle in Ma'avar Yabok that suffering and illness serve as divine instruction, guiding sinners back to the proper path through the experience of physical affliction.
[4] The Hebrew word 'sod' (secret) is particularly significant in Jewish mystical tradition, where it represents the deepest, esoteric level of Torah interpretation. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would suggest that proper spiritual preparation grants access to divine mysteries, especially relevant when facing mortality.

[iv] The psalm begins with the soul's lifting or raising toward God, a theme particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of preparing the soul for its ultimate ascent during illness and death.
[i] This plea for God to forget youthful transgressions aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession (vidui) before death as a means of spiritual purification. In the book's kabbalistic framework, such confession literally removes spiritual blemishes.
[ii] The term 'sod' (secret or mystery) has special significance in Jewish mystical tradition, referring to the deepest, esoteric level of Torah interpretation. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would suggest that those who properly fear God receive special spiritual insight, particularly relevant when approaching death.

וְשִׁנְאַת חָמָס שְׂנֵאוּנִי: שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי
וְהַצִּילֵנִי אֵל־אֶבוֹשׁ כִּי־חָסִיתִי
בָךְ: תֹּם־וְיֹשֶׁר יִצְּרוּנִי כִּי קִוִּיתִיךָ:
פְּדֵה אֱלֹהִים אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל מִכֹּל
צָרוֹתָיו׃[i][ii]

me, for I am lonely and afflicted. The troubles of my heart have expanded;[A] bring me out of my distresses. Look upon my affliction and my toil, and forgive all my sins. Look upon my enemies, for they are many, and they hate me with violent hatred. Guard my soul and deliver me; let me not be ashamed, for I have taken refuge in You. Let integrity and uprightness preserve me, for I wait for You. Redeem Israel, O God, from all its troubles.[1]

(תהלים כח) לְדָוִד אֵלֶיךָ
יְיָ אֶקְרָא צוּרִי אַל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ
מִמֶּנִּי פֶּן־תֶּחֱשֶׁה מִמֶּנִּי וְנִמְשַׁלְתִּי
עִם־יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר[iii]: שְׁמַע קוֹל
תַּחֲנוּנַי בְּשַׁוְּעִי אֵלֶיךָ בְּנָשְׂאִי יָדַי
אֵל־דְּבִיר קָדְשֶׁךָ[iv]: אַל־תִּמְשְׁכֵנִי
עִם־רְשָׁעִים וְעִם־פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן
דֹּבְרֵי שָׁלוֹם עִם־רֵעֵיהֶם וְרָעָה

(Psalm 28) Of David. To You, O LORD, I call; my Rock, do not be deaf to me,[2] lest if You are silent to me, I will become like those who descend to the pit.[3] Hear the voice of my supplications when I cry to You, when I lift my hands toward Your holy sanctuary. Do not drag me away with the wicked and with evildoers, who speak peace with their neighbors while evil is in their hearts.[4] Give them according to

[A] Or: "The distresses of my heart have grown great" — This alternative more directly conveys the intensification of suffering, which would resonate with the experience of progressive illness as described in Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] The psalm concludes by moving from individual to communal concerns, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's understanding that proper spiritual practice during illness creates merit not only for the individual but for the entire community.

[2] The Hebrew uses two different verbs with similar meaning: 'אַל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ' (do not be deaf/silent) and 'פֶּן־תֶּחֱשֶׁה' (lest you be silent). This repetition emphasizes the psalmist's urgent need for divine response, reflecting the anxiety of someone seriously ill seeking assurance of God's attention.

[3] In Jewish tradition, 'the pit' (בּוֹר) represents both the physical grave and Sheol, the shadowy underworld realm of the dead. In Ma'avar Yabok, this image would resonate particularly with those facing terminal illness, expressing fear of joining the dead without divine intervention.

[4] This description of duplicitous speech may seem unexpected in a healing prayer, but in Ma'avar Yabok's context, it distinguishes the sincere prayers of the ill person from insincere religious practices. The book emphasizes that genuine confession and prayer are crucial for spiritual healing.

[i] The psalm concludes with a collective prayer for all Israel rather than just the individual, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's understanding that proper spiritual practice during illness and death benefits not only the individual but the entire community.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This psalm appears in the third liturgical order (Seder Gimel) of Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms recommended for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine guidance, plea for forgiveness, and trust in divine protection make it particularly appropriate for those facing illness or approaching death. | Cf. Psalm 25 — Psalm 25 is an acrostic psalm (though with some irregularities) arranged by the letters of the Hebrew alphabet. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a prayer of supplication that combines confession of sin with expressions of trust in divine mercy and guidance. | Cf. Talmud — The Talmud recommends reciting prayers for divine protection when traveling on dangerous roads. The imagery in Psalm 25 of God leading one on proper paths and freeing feet from snares would resonate with the book's metaphorical understanding of illness and death as a journey requiring divine guidance.

[iii] The phrase 'those who descend to the pit' refers to the dead or those approaching death. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this resonates with the book's focus on the transition between life and death, with the psalmist expressing fear of joining those who have died without divine intervention.

[iv] The physical gesture of lifting hands toward the sanctuary represents both a ritual prayer position and, in kabbalistic understanding, creates a spiritual channel connecting the worshipper to divine realms. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes the importance of proper physical gestures during prayer for the sick.

בִּלְבָבָם: תֵּן־לָהֶם כְּפָעֳלָם וּכְרֹעַ
מַעַלְלֵיהֶם כְּמַעֲשֵׂה יְדֵיהֶם תֵּן
לָהֶם הָשֵׁב גְּמוּלָם לָהֶם: כִּי לֹא
יָבִינוּ אֶל־פְּעֻלֹּת יְיָ [i] וְאֶל־מַעֲשֵׂה
יָדָיו יֶהֶרְסֵם וְלֹא יִבְנֵם: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ
כִּי־שָׁמַע קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי: יְיָ עֻזִּי וּמָגִנִּי
בּוֹ בָטַח לִבִּי וְנֶעֱזָרְתִּי וַיַּעַלֹז לִבִּי
וּמִשִּׁירִי אֲהוֹדֶנּוּ: יְיָ עֹז־לָמוֹ וּמָעוֹז
יְשׁוּעוֹת מְשִׁיחוֹ הוּא: הוֹשִׁיעָה
אֶת־עַמֶּךָ וּבָרֵךְ אֶת־נַחֲלָתֶךָ וּרְעֵם
וְנַשְּׂאֵם עַד־הָעוֹלָם [ii] [iii]:

their deeds and according to the wickedness of their actions; according to the work of their hands give to them, return their recompense to them. Because they do not understand the works of the LORD or the deeds of His hands, He will tear them down and not build them up. Blessed is the LORD, for He has heard the voice of my supplications. The LORD is my strength and my shield; in Him my heart trusted, and I have been helped. Therefore my heart exults, and with my song I will praise Him.[1] The LORD is strength to them, and He is the stronghold of salvation for His anointed.[2] Save Your people and bless Your inheritance; shepherd them and carry them forever.

630R

635R

640R

(תהלים ל) מִזְמוֹר שִׁיר־חֲנֻכַּת
הַבַּיִת לְדָוִד: אֲרוֹמִמְךָ יְיָ כִּי
דִלִּיתָנִי וְלֹא־שִׂמַּחְתָּ אֹיְבַי לִי: יְיָ
אֱלֹהָי שִׁוַּעְתִּי אֵלֶיךָ וַתִּרְפָּאֵנִי:
יְיָ הֶעֱלִיתָ מִן־שְׁאוֹל נַפְשִׁי

(Psalm 30) A Psalm, a song for the dedication of the House,[3] by David. I will exalt You, O LORD, for You have drawn me up[4] and have not let my enemies rejoice over me. O LORD my God, I cried out to You and You healed me. O LORD, You have

645R

[1] The Hebrew term 'מִשִּׁירִי' literally means 'from my song,' suggesting that praise emerges naturally from the experience of divine salvation. In Ma'avar Yabok, song and prayer are understood as spiritual remedies that both express gratitude and continue the healing process.

[2] The term 'מְשִׁיחוֹ' (His anointed) historically referred to the king of Israel but gained messianic connotations over time. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this verse would be understood as affirming that God provides special protection to the righteous, particularly relevant for a seriously ill person seeking divine favor.

[3] This psalm appears in the third liturgical order (Seder Gimel) of Ma'avar Yabok, specifically selected for recitation for the sick. Its themes of healing, divine rescue from the grave, and transformation of mourning into joy make it particularly relevant for those seeking recovery from illness.

[4] The image of being drawn up (as from a well) creates a powerful metaphor for recovery from illness, especially when paired with the subsequent reference to Sheol (the realm of the dead). In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this symbolizes both physical healing and spiritual elevation.

[i] This verse reflects the theological framework of Ma'avar Yabok that understanding divine purpose in suffering is crucial. Those who fail to perceive God's works lack spiritual insight and face destruction, while the sick person who recognizes divine purpose in illness can find meaning and salvation.

[ii] The request that God 'shepherd and carry them forever' connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on divine care continuing beyond death. The verb 'נְשָׂאֵם' (carry them) evokes the image of being lifted up, which in the context of illness suggests both physical recovery and spiritual elevation.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's Seder Section — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, Psalm 28 serves as a powerful prayer for the ill, combining urgent pleas for divine attention with expressions of trust in divine protection. The opening plea 'do not be deaf to me' and comparison to 'those who descend to the pit' would resonate powerfully with a seriously ill person facing the possibility of death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli — The gesture of lifting hands toward the sanctuary in verse 2 parallels ritual gestures during prayer for the sick in Jewish tradition, including turning toward Jerusalem/the sanctuary. In Ma'avar Yabok, this physical orientation during prayer is given mystical significance as creating a channel for divine healing energy. | Cf. Zohar — The confidence expressed in verse 6 'Blessed is the LORD, for He has heard the voice of my supplications' aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic teaching that properly offered prayers penetrate the heavens and receive divine response, especially during illness when the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) hovers near the sick person.

חִיִּיתַנִי (מִיּוֹרְדִי־)[מִיָּרְדִי־]בוֹר׃
זַמְּרוּ לַיהוָה חֲסִידָיו וְהוֹדוּ לְזֵכֶר
קָדְשׁוֹ׃ כִּי רֶגַע בְּאַפּוֹ חַיִּים בִּרְצוֹנוֹ
600 בָּעֶרֶב יָלִין בֶּכִי וְלַבֹּקֶר רִנָּה׃
וַאֲנִי אָמַרְתִּי בְשַׁלְוִי בַּל־אֶמּוֹט
לְעוֹלָם׃ יְיָ בִּרְצוֹנְךָ הֶעֱמַדְתָּה
לְהַרְרִי־עֹז הִסְתַּרְתָּ פָּנֶיךָ הָיִיתִי
נִבְהָל׃ אֵלֶיךָ יְיָ אֶקְרָא וְאֶל־אֲדֹנָי
605 אֶתְחַנָּן׃ מַה־בֶּצַע בְּדָמִי בְּרִדְתִּי
אֶל־שָׁחַת הֲיוֹדְךָ עָפָר הֲיַגִּיד
אֲמִתֶּךָ׃ שְׁמַע־יְיָ וְחָנֵּנִי יְיָ הֱיֵה־עֹזֵר
לִי׃ הָפַכְתָּ מִסְפְּדִי לְמָחוֹל לִי
פִּתַּחְתָּ שַׂקִּי וַתְּאַזְּרֵנִי שִׂמְחָה׃ לְמַעַן
610 יְזַמֶּרְךָ כָבוֹד וְלֹא יִדֹּם יְיָ אֱלֹהַי
[i] לְעוֹלָם אוֹדֶךָּ׃

brought up my soul from Sheol;[A] You have kept me alive from among those who descend to the pit.[1] Sing to the LORD, O His faithful ones, and give thanks 650R
to His holy remembrance. For His anger lasts but a moment, life is in His favor;[2] weeping may lodge for the night, but in the morning there is joyful singing. As for me, I said in my tranquility, "I shall never be moved." O LORD, by Your favor You established 655R
strength for my mountain; when You hid Your face, I was terrified.[3] To You, O LORD, I called, and to my Lord I made supplication. "What profit is there in my blood, in my going down to the pit? Will dust praise You? Will it declare Your truth?"[4] Hear, 660R
O LORD, and be gracious to me; O LORD, be my helper. You have turned my mourning into dancing for me;[B] You have opened my sackcloth and girded me with gladness. So that my glory may sing praise to You and not be silent;[C] O LORD my God, I will 665R
thank You forever.[5]

(תורה) עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ[i] וַיְהִי לִי

(Torah) The LORD is my strength and song,[6] and He

[A]Or: "O LORD, You have raised my soul from the depths of the grave" — This translation makes the metaphor of rescue from death more explicit for modern readers who might not recognize the significance of 'Sheol' as the realm of the dead. It preserves the vertical imagery of being lifted up from below, which is important to the psalm's movement.

[B]Or: "You have transformed my lamentation into celebratory dancing for me" — This translation emphasizes the complete transformation from deepest grief to highest joy, highlighting the dramatic nature of divine healing that is central to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of recovery from illness as spiritual redemption.

[A]Or: "So that my soul may sing praise to You and not be silent" — The Hebrew כָּבוֹד (kavod/glory) is sometimes interpreted as referring specifically to the soul or innermost being in contexts of praise. This translation makes the metaphysical dimension more explicit, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's frequent emphasis on the soul's relationship with God.

[1]This verse would be especially meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical context, as it portrays recovery from serious illness as a rescue from death itself, reinforcing the book's view of healing as divine redemption.

[2]This verse aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that presents suffering as temporary divine correction, while healing reflects God's essential attribute of mercy. The contrast between momentary anger and enduring favor offers comfort to the sick.

[3]The concept of divine concealment (hester panim) is significant in Jewish mysticism. In Ma'avar Yabok, illness is often portrayed as a temporary concealment of divine favor that can be reversed through proper prayer and repentance.

[4]This rhetorical question forms a central theological argument in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to healing prayers: that God benefits more from the continued life and praise of His servants than from their death. This becomes a basis for petitioning God for recovery.

[1]The psalm concludes with a commitment to eternal gratitude, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context serves both as a promise from the sick person and as a reminder that recovery from illness creates an obligation for continued devotion and thanksgiving.

[2]The Hebrew phrase 'ozi v'zimrat Yah' is complex and has been variously translated. Some

[i]Cf. Zohar — The psalm's journey from illness to healing parallels the Zoharic teaching that suffering can lead to spiritual elevation when properly responded to with prayer. Ma'avar Yabok incorporates this psalm within its healing liturgy to activate this spiritual principle. | Cf. Tal-

לִישׁוּעָה: זֶה אֵלִי וְאַנְוֵהוּ אֱלֹהֵי
אָבִי וַאֲרֹמְמֶנְהוּ: יְהוָה יִלָּחֶם לָכֶם
615 וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִישׁוּן:[ii] וַיֹּאמֶר אִם
שָׁמוֹעַ תִּשְׁמַע לְקוֹל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ
וְהַיָּשָׁר בְּעֵינָיו תַּעֲשֶׂה וְהַאֲזַנְתָּ
לְמִצְוֹתָיו וְשָׁמַרְתָּ כָּל חֻקָּיו כָּל
הַמַּחֲלָה אֲשֶׁר שַׂמְתִּי בְמִצְרַיִם
620 לֹא אָשִׂים עָלֶיךָ כִּי אֲנִי יְהוָה
רֹפְאֶךָ:[iii] וְאֵל שַׁדַּי יְבָרֵךְ אֹתְךָ
וַיַּפְרְךָ וְיַרְבֶּךָ וְהָיִיתָ לְקָהַל עַמִּים:
בְּכָל הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר אַזְכִּיר אֶת שְׁמִי
אָבוֹא אֵלֶיךָ וּבֵרַכְתִּיךָ: וַעֲבַדְתֶּם
625 אֵת יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם וּבֵרַךְ אֶת
לַחְמְךָ וְאֶת מֵימֶיךָ וַהֲסִרֹתִי מַחֲלָה
מִקִּרְבֶּךָ:[iv]

has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will glorify Him; my father's God, and I will exalt Him. The LORD will fight for you, and you shall hold your 670R
peace. And He said: "If you will diligently hearken to the voice of the LORD your God, and will do that which is right in His eyes, and will give ear to His commandments, and keep all His statutes, I will put none of the diseases upon you which I have put upon 675R
the Egyptians; for I am the LORD who heals you." And God Almighty bless you, and make you fruitful, and multiply you, that you may be a congregation of peoples.[1] In every place where I cause My name to be mentioned I will come to you and bless you. And 680R
you shall serve the LORD your God, and He will bless your bread, and your water; and I will remove

scholars understand it as 'the LORD is my strength and protection' or 'the LORD is my strength and might.' The translation here follows the traditional understanding found in most Jewish liturgy.

[3]The phrase 'congregation of peoples' (k'hal amim) suggests both numerical increase and the formation of a structured community. This blessing, originally given to Jacob, connects individual healing and prosperity to communal flourishing.

mud — The psalm's affirmation that God's anger lasts only a moment while His favor brings life aligns with the Talmudic concept that suffering is temporary and purposeful, ultimately leading to purification and healing when properly received. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This psalm's inclusion in Seder Gimel reflects its thematic appropriateness for healing prayers, as it moves from illness to recovery, from divine concealment to revelation, and from mourning to dancing—mirroring the desired transformation in the sick person's condition. | Cf. Isaiah 38 — Both Psalm 30 and Hezekiah's prayer emphasize that the dead cannot praise God, using this theological argument as a basis for requesting healing. Ma'avar Yabok incorporates both texts in its healing liturgy, reinforcing the idea that recovery from illness allows continued divine service.

[ii]This opening phrase from the Song at the Sea (Exodus 15:2) is particularly significant in healing contexts. The word 'zimrat' (song/praise) shares its root with 'zamir' (pruning), suggesting that praise of God both expresses strength and cuts away spiritual obstacles to healing.

[i]The instruction to 'remain silent' or 'hold your peace' presents a theological approach to healing where human action sometimes gives way to divine intervention. This creates a balance with the other verses that emphasize obedience and active service.

[ii]God's self-identification as 'your healer' establishes divine healing as an essential divine attribute rather than an occasional action. This title appears in a context linking healing to obedience, a connection maintained throughout biblical and rabbinic literature.

[iii]Cf. Exodus 15:2-3 — These verses are particularly significant in a healing context as they emphasize God's role as a deliverer and protector. The selection connects physical healing to the paradigmatic redemption from Egypt, suggesting that current affliction can likewise end in salvation. | Cf. Exodus 14:14 — This verse emphasizes divine intervention requiring human passivity, suggesting that healing ultimately comes from God while humans must trust in divine protection. | Cf. Exodus 15:26 — This verse directly addresses divine healing, establishing God's self-identification as 'your healer' (רֹפְאֶךָ). It connects physical health to spiritual obedience, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness. | Cf. Genesis 28:3-4 — This blessing invokes divine fertility and abundance, connecting physical well-being to divine blessing. The mention of becoming 'a congregation of peoples' suggests communal dimensions of blessing that extend beyond individual healing. | Cf. Exodus 20:21 — This verse connects divine blessing to places where God's name is invoked, suggesting that prayer and divine invocation in sacred contexts facilitates healing and blessing. | Cf. Exodus 23:25 — This verse directly links divine service to physical well-being, promising both sustenance (blessed bread and water) and health (removal of sickness), reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's connection between spiritual practice and physical healing.

sickness from your midst.[1]

(נביאים) כִּי אֲנִי יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ
מַחֲזִיק יְמִינֶךָ הָאֹמֵר לְךָ אַל תִּירָא
630 אֲנִי עֲזַרְתִּיךָ: הֵן עַבְדִּי אֶתְמָךְ
בּוֹ[i] בְּחִירִי רָצְתָה נַפְשִׁי נָתַתִּי רוּחִי
עָלָיו מִשְׁפָּט לַגּוֹיִם יוֹצִיא: לְמַעַן
שְׁמִי אַאֲרִיךְ אַפִּי וּתְהִלָּתִי אֶחֱטָם
לָךְ[ii] לְבִלְתִּי הַכְרִיתֶךָ: אַל תִּירָא
635 כִּי עִמְּךָ אָנִי אַל תִּשְׁתָּע כִּי אֲנִי
אֱלֹהֶיךָ אִמַּצְתִּיךָ אַף עֲזַרְתִּיךָ אַף
תְּמַכְתִּיךָ בִּימִין צִדְקִי: לְמַעֲנִי
לְמַעֲנִי אֶעֱשֶׂה כִּי אֵיךְ יֵחָל וּכְבוֹדִי
לְאַחֵר לֹא אֶתֵּן: וַיֹּאמֶר לִי עַבְדִּי
640 אָתָּה יִשְׂרָאֵל אֲשֶׁר בְּךָ אֶתְפָּאָר:
הֵן אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה יַעֲזָר לִי מִי הוּא
יַרְשִׁיעֵנִי הֵן כֻּלָּם כַּבֶּגֶד יִבְלוּ עָשׁ
יֹאכְלֵם: וַאדֹנָי יְהוִה יַעֲזָר לִי עַל
כֵּן לֹא נִכְלָמְתִּי עַל כֵּן שַׂמְתִּי פָנַי
645 כַּחַלָּמִישׁ[iii] וָאֵדַע כִּי לֹא אֵבוֹשׁ:

(Prophets) For I am the LORD your God who grasps your right hand,[2] who says to you, "Fear not, I will help you." Behold My servant, whom I uphold, My chosen one in whom My soul delights; I have placed My spirit upon him, he shall bring forth justice to the nations. For the sake of My name I will restrain My anger, and for My praise I will hold it back from you,[3] so that I will not cut you off. Fear not, for I am with you; be not dismayed,[A] for I am your God. I will strengthen you, I will help you, I will even uphold you[B] with My righteous right hand.[4] For My own sake, for My own sake, I will act, for how should My name be profaned?[C] And My glory I will not give to another. And He said to me, "You are My servant, Israel, in whom I will be glorified." Behold, the Lord GOD will help me; who is he that will condemn me? Lo, they shall all wear out like a garment; the moth shall consume them. And the Lord GOD helps

685R 690R 695R 700R

[A] Or: "do not be anxious" — The Hebrew word תִּשְׁתָּע (tishta) is relatively uncommon and has connotations of anxiety or distress. While 'dismayed' captures the emotional state well, 'anxious' might be more accessible to modern readers while preserving the meaning.

[B] Or: "I strengthen you, I help you, I uphold you" — The Hebrew uses perfect tense verbs that can be translated either as future or present tense depending on context. In this passage of divine reassurance, present tense might better convey the immediacy of God's ongoing support rather than just a future promise.

[C] Or: "for how could it be profaned?" — The Hebrew phrase is elliptical, not explicitly mentioning 'My name' though this is implied from context. A more literal translation preserves this ambiguity while maintaining the rhetorical force of the question.

[1] The promise to remove sickness appears in a context of serving God and receiving blessed sustenance, establishing a holistic approach to health that includes spiritual practice, proper nutrition, and divine intervention—all themes developed extensively in Ma'avar Yabok.

[2] This opening verse establishes an intimate, physical metaphor of divine support—God holding the person's hand like a parent with a child or a guide helping someone through difficult terrain. This imagery would be especially comforting to someone experiencing illness.

[3] The Hebrew construction is ambiguous about whether God is restraining anger 'for you' (beneficially) or 'from you' (hiding it). I've chosen 'from you' as it better connects with the following phrase about not cutting the person off.

[4] The image of God's 'righteous right hand' combines two powerful biblical motifs: divine righteousness (moral perfection) and the right hand (strength and favor). For the ill person, this promises both moral and physical support from God's perfect power.

[i] This phrase from Isaiah 42:1 begins a prophetic passage about God's servant that was traditionally interpreted by Jews as referring to Israel collectively, while Christians later interpreted it as referring to Jesus. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, it offers reassurance that God upholds those who are weak or suffering.

[ii] The Hebrew verb אֶחֱטָם (echtom) is rare and appears only in Isaiah 48:9. It likely derives from a root meaning 'to bridle' or 'to muzzle,' creating a powerful image of God restraining His anger as one might bridle a horse.

[iii] This powerful metaphor compares the face to flint stone, expressing resolute determination and unshakable confidence in divine support despite opposition. In the context of illness, it offers a model of spiritual resilience for the suffering person.

בַּיהוָה יִצְדְּקוּ וְיִתְהַלְלוּ כָּל זֶרַע
יִשְׂרָאֵל: גַּאֲלֵנוּ יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת שְׁמוֹ
קְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל: וּפְדוּיֵי יְהוָה יְשֻׁבוּן
וּבָאוּ צִיּוֹן בְּרִנָּה וְשִׂמְחַת עוֹלָם עַל
650 רֹאשָׁם שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה יַשִּׂיגוּ וְנָסוּ
יָגוֹן וַאֲנָחָה: [i] חָשַׂף יְהוָה אֶת זְרוֹעַ
קָדְשׁוֹ לְעֵינֵי כָל הַגּוֹיִם וְרָאוּ כָל
אַפְסֵי אָרֶץ אֶת יְשׁוּעַת אֱלֹהֵינוּ: [ii]

me; therefore I have not been disgraced; therefore I have set my face like flint, and I know that I shall not be ashamed. In the LORD shall all the seed of Israel be justified and glory. Our Redeemer, the 705R
LORD of hosts is His name, the Holy One of Israel. And the ransomed of the LORD shall return and come to Zion with singing, with everlasting joy upon their heads;[1] they shall obtain gladness and joy, and sorrow and sighing shall flee away. The LORD has 710R
bared His holy arm in the sight of all the nations, and all the ends of the earth shall see the salvation of our God.

(כתובים) כִּי אֹרֶךְ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת
655 חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם יוֹסִיפוּ לָךְ: חַיִּים
שָׁאַל מִמְּךָ נָתַתָּ לּוֹ אֹרֶךְ יָמִים עוֹלָם
וָעֶד: כִּי תְקַדְּמֶנּוּ בִּרְכוֹת טוֹב
תָּשִׁית לְרֹאשׁוֹ עֲטֶרֶת פָּז: וַתִּתֶּן לִי
מָגֵן יְשֻׁעֶךָ וִימִינְךָ תִסְעָדֵנִי וְעַנְוָתְךָ
660 תַּרְבֵּנִי: כִּי בְךָ אָרֶץ גְּדוּד וּבֵאלֹהַי
אֲדַלֶּג שׁוּר: [iii] אֶרְחַץ בְּנָקִיּוֹן
כַּפַּי [iv] וַאֲסֹבְבָה אֶת מִזְבַּחֲךָ יְהוָה:

(From the Writings) For length of days and years of life and peace they will add to you. He asked life of 715R
You, and You gave it to him, length of days forever and ever.[2] For You meet him with blessings of goodness; You set a crown of fine gold on his head.[3] You have given me the shield of Your salvation; Your right hand upholds me, and Your gentleness makes 720R
me great.[A] For by You I can run against a troop, and by my God I can leap over a wall. I will wash

[A] Or: "and Your humility exalts me" — The Hebrew term ענוה (anavah) can refer to humility or gentleness. In this context, it creates a paradox where God's humility (willingness to lower Himself to help humans) results in human exaltation. This alternate translation preserves this theological paradox that would be familiar to kabbalistic readers.

[1] The Hebrew metaphor of joy being 'upon their heads' suggests joy as a crown or visible manifestation, creating a striking contrast with the illness or suffering the person might currently be experiencing. This offers hope that their current condition will be replaced by visible, permanent joy.

[2] This verse from Psalm 21:4 was originally about the king but is repurposed in Ma'avar Yabok as a prayer for the sick person's longevity. The phrase 'forever and ever' would be understood as hyperbole when applied to earthly life but also as an allusion to eternal life in the World to Come.

[3] In the kabbalistic context of Ma'avar Yabok, this crown imagery would be interpreted as the divine light that surrounds and protects the head of the righteous, particularly during illness. Crowns frequently symbolize spiritual attainment and divine protection in Jewish mystical literature.

[i] This poetic closing phrase about sorrow and sighing fleeing away would be particularly comforting to those in physical pain or emotional distress, offering a vision of complete restoration where all suffering is permanently removed.

[ii] Cf. Isaiah — This passage compiles verses from multiple chapters in Isaiah that focus on divine comfort, protection, and redemption. These verses were selected for their reassuring themes of God strengthening the weak, helping the fearful, and promising ultimate redemption. In Ma'avar Yabok, they serve as divine assurances for the sick person, offering spiritual comfort through prophetic promises of divine support and eventual salvation. | Cf. Seder Te'fillah (Prayer liturgy) — The compiler of Ma'avar Yabok adopted the traditional liturgical practice of stringing together thematically related biblical verses to create a spiritually potent prayer sequence. This method reflects the Jewish understanding that biblical verses retain their spiritual power when recited, especially in moments of vulnerability like illness.

[iii] The image of 'leaping over a wall' was particularly meaningful in the context of illness, suggesting that with divine help, the sufferer could overcome seemingly insurmountable obstacles to recovery.

[iv] This reference to ritual washing connects physical purification with spiritual cleansing, a theme that appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to healing. In kabbalistic interpretation, physical actions like washing create corresponding spiritual effects.

רַגְלִי עָמְדָה בְמִישׁוֹר בְּמַקְהֲלִים
אֲבָרֵךְ יְהוָה: אַחַת שָׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת
665 יְהוָה אוֹתָהּ אֲבַקֵּשׁ שִׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית
יְהוָה כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי לַחֲזוֹת בְּנֹעַם
יְהוָה [i]וּלְבַקֵּר בְּהֵיכָלוֹ: אַל תַּסְתֵּר
פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי אַל תַּט בְּאַף עַבְדֶּךָ
עֶזְרָתִי הָיִיתָ אַל תִּטְּשֵׁנִי וְאַל
670 תַּעַזְבֵנִי אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי: כִּי אָבִי וְאִמִּי
עֲזָבוּנִי וַיהוָה יַאַסְפֵנִי: הוֹרֵנִי
יְהוָה דַּרְכֶּךָ וּנְחֵנִי בְּאֹרַח מִישׁוֹר
לְמַעַן שׁוֹרְרָי: אַל תִּתְּנֵנִי בְּנֶפֶשׁ
צָרָי כִּי
675 חֲיָי: אַל תִּתְּנֵנִי בְּנֶפֶשׁ צָרָי כִּי
קָמוּ בִי עֵדֵי שֶׁקֶר וְיפֵחַ חָמָס:
וַאֲנִי בְּתָמִּי אֵלֵךְ פְּדֵנִי וְחָנֵּנִי:
לוּלֵא הֶאֱמַנְתִּי לִרְאוֹת בְּטוּב יְהוָה
בְּאֶרֶץ חַיִּים: הַנְּהֹ עֵין יְהוָה אֶל
680 יְרֵאָיו לַמְיַחֲלִים לְחַסְדּוֹ: לְהַצִּיל
מִמָּוֶת נַפְשָׁם וּלְחַיּוֹתָם בָּרָעָב: קַוֵּה
אֶל יְהוָה חֲזַק וְיַאֲמֵץ לִבֶּךָ וְקַוֵּה
[ii]אֶל יְהוָה:

my hands in innocence, and I will go around Your altar, O LORD. My foot stands on level ground; in
665 the congregations I will bless the LORD.[A] One thing 725R
I have asked of the LORD, that will I seek: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to behold the pleasantness of the LORD and to inquire in His temple. Do not hide Your face
670 from me; do not turn Your servant away in anger. 730R
You have been my help; do not leave me nor forsake me, O God of my salvation.[B] For my father and my mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take me in. Teach me Your way, O LORD, and lead me
675 in a straight path because of my enemies. Do not 735R
deliver me to the desire of my adversaries, for false witnesses have risen against me, and they breathe out violence. I would have lost heart, unless I had believed that I would see the goodness of the LORD
680 in the land of the living.[1] Behold, the eye of the 740R
LORD is on those who fear Him, on those who hope in His mercy, to deliver their soul from death, and to keep them alive in famine. Wait for the LORD; be strong, and let your heart take courage; wait for the LORD.[2] 745R

[A] Or: "in the assemblies I will praise the LORD" — The term מַקְהֲלִים (makhelim) refers to gatherings or assemblies, while the verb אֲבָרֵךְ (avarech) can mean either 'bless' or 'praise' depending on context. This alternate translation emphasizes the public, communal nature of thanksgiving after healing, which would be relevant to Ma'avar Yabok's focus on both individual and communal responses to illness and recovery.

[B] Or: "nor abandon me, O God of my deliverance" — The term ישע (yesha) encompasses both salvation in the spiritual sense and physical deliverance/rescue. In the context of prayers for healing in Ma'avar Yabok, emphasizing the physical 'deliverance' aspect might better reflect the immediate concerns of someone who is ill.

[1] The phrase 'land of the living' (בְּאֶרֶץ חַיִּים) has multiple interpretations in Jewish tradition. In the immediate context of prayers for healing, it refers to this world and continued physical life. However, in Ma'avar Yabok's eschatological framework, it also alludes to the World to Come where souls experience eternal life.

[2] This concluding exhortation to 'wait for the LORD' appears twice for emphasis, creating a pow-

[i] The phrase 'to behold the pleasantness of the LORD' would be interpreted in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework as referring to the mystic vision of divine light, which was believed to have healing properties. This connects the physical healing sought through these prayers with spiritual illumination.

[ii] Cf. Book of Psalms — These verses have been compiled as part of a prayer sequence for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok. The selections focus on divine protection, healing, and spiritual comfort, emphasizing God's power to sustain life and the psalmist's desire to dwell in God's presence. The compiler has intentionally selected verses that transition from expressions of confidence in God's protection to direct petitions for divine intervention and guidance, concluding with encouragement to wait hopefully for divine deliverance. | Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok's selection of these verses reflects its kabbalistic understanding that reciting scriptural passages with proper intention activates spiritual channels of healing. The references to God's gentleness (וַעֲנָוָתְךָ) and right hand (וימינך) would be understood as references to specific divine attributes (sefirot) through which healing flows, particularly Chesed (loving-kindness) and Tiferet (harmony).

	יאמר למען יחלצון ידידיך	He shall say[1] "That Your beloved ones may be
685	וגו׳[i] רפאני ה׳ וגו׳[ii] וגומר ככל	delivered..."[A] and "Heal me, O LORD..." and
	הסדר הכתוב למעלה[iii] עד צורי	continue with the entire order written above,[B] until
	וגואלי׳[iv]	"my Rock and my Redeemer."[2]
	סדר ד׳[v][vi]	Order Four[3] 750R

[A] Or: "For the sake of Your beloved ones being delivered..." — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the intercessory nature of the prayer, where the supplicant is invoking God's compassion toward His beloved ones as a reason for divine intervention.

[B] Or: "following the complete liturgical sequence written above" — This alternate translation makes clearer that the text is referring to a specific liturgical arrangement or prayer sequence that has been previously detailed in the text.

erful conclusion to this prayer compilation. For the sick person, it encourages patient endurance during illness with confident expectation of divine intervention.

[1] The original Hebrew uses the third-person impersonal form 'יאמר' (he shall say), which is a standard format for liturgical instructions. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's function as a manual for those performing deathbed rituals.

[2] This phrase from Psalms 19:15 serves as the standard conclusion to the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok. The metaphors of God as both 'Rock' (stability, protection) and 'Redeemer' (rescuer, liberator) are particularly appropriate in the context of prayers for the sick and dying.

[3] This simple header marks the beginning of the fourth structured liturgical sequence in Ma'avar Yabok. Each of the eight 'sedarim' (orders) follows a similar pattern: opening with prayers beginning with 'Ana Hashem hoshiah na' (Please, O LORD, save us), continuing with specific psalms (in this case including Psalm 31 with its important verse 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit'), followed by collections of biblical verses organized by source (Torah, Prophets, Writings), and concluding with standardized healing formulas.

[i] This introduces a standard prayer formula beginning with a verse from Psalms 60:7/108:7. The abbreviation "וגו׳" (etc.) indicates that the user should recite the complete verse, which would have been well-known to the intended audience.

[ii] This refers to Jeremiah 17:14, "Heal me, O LORD, and I shall be healed; save me, and I shall be saved, for You are my praise." The abbreviated form assumes the reader knows the complete verse.

[iii] This instruction refers back to a previously detailed prayer sequence, showing that Ma'avar Yabok was designed as a practical manual with recurring elements that did not need to be repeated in full each time.

[iv] Cf. Psalms 60:7 — This verse from Psalms is used as the opening of a prayer sequence. In the original psalm, it expresses a plea for God to save His beloved people. In Ma'avar Yabok, it's repurposed as part of a healing prayer for the sick, invoking God's special relationship with His people as grounds for divine intervention and healing. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This direct appeal for divine healing from Jeremiah forms a centerpiece of the prayer sequence for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok. The prophet's personal plea for healing is repurposed as a universal prayer appropriate for any sick person, emphasizing that true healing comes only from God. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This line shows that Ma'avar Yabok was structured as a practical manual with repeating elements. Rather than repeating identical prayer sequences multiple times, the author provides detailed instructions once and then refers back to them. The reference to 'my Rock and my Redeemer' (from Psalms 19:15) indicates where the repeated sequence should end.

[v] This is a section header for the fourth liturgical sequence (Seder Dalet) in Ma'avar Yabok's collection of eight prayer orders for healing the sick and comforting the dying.

[vi] Cf. Psalm 31 — Psalm 31 is specifically included in the fourth liturgical order because it contains the verse 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit,' which is considered especially appropriate for the dying as an expression of surrendering one's soul to divine care. | Cf. Ana Hashem hoshiah na — The phrase 'Please, O LORD, save us' serves as a standardized opening for all eight prayer orders, creating ritual continuity throughout the book's liturgical framework for healing the sick and dying. | Cf. Memory Note #3042 — The section header 'Seder Dalet' (Order Four) identifies this as the fourth of eight structured prayer sequences, each following a consistent pattern: opening with 'Ana Hashem,' continuing with specific psalms, followed by biblical verses organized by source, and concluding with standardized healing formulas.

יתחיל אנא ה׳ הושיעה נא וגו׳ ככתוב למעלה בסדר א׳[i] ואחר כך יאמר מזמור ל״א או ל״ח או מ׳ או ע״א[ii] אח״כ יאמר כי אל רחום:[iii][iv]

He shall begin[1] "Please, O LORD, save us, etc."[2] as written above in Order 1, and afterward he shall recite Psalm 31 or 38 or 40 or 71, then he shall say "For God is merciful."[3]

(תהלים לא) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד: בְּךָ־יְיָ חָסִיתִי אַל־אֵבוֹשָׁה לְעוֹלָם בְּצִדְקָתְךָ פַּלְּטֵנִי: הַטֵּה אֵלַי אָזְנְךָ מְהֵרָה הַצִּילֵנִי הֱיֵה לִי לְצוּר־מָעוֹז לְבֵית מְצוּדוֹת לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי: כִּי־סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי אָתָּה וּלְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ תַּנְחֵנִי וּתְנַהֲלֵנִי: תּוֹצִיאֵנִי מֵרֶשֶׁת זוּ טָמְנוּ לִי כִּי־אַתָּה מָעוּזִּי: בְּיָדְךָ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי פָּדִיתָ אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת: שָׂנֵאתִי הַשֹּׁמְרִים הַבְלֵי־שָׁוְא

(Psalm 31) For the Chief Musician. A Psalm of David. In You, O LORD, I have taken refuge; let me never be put to shame; deliver me in Your righteousness. Incline Your ear to me, rescue me quickly; be to me a rock of strength, a fortress to save me. For You are my rock and my stronghold; for Your name's sake, lead me and guide me. Release me from the net they have hidden for me, for You are my strength. Into Your hand I commit my spirit;[A] You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth. I hate those who revere worthless idols,[B] but I trust in the LORD. I

[A] Or: "Into Your hand I entrust my soul" — The Hebrew "ruchi" (רוּחִי) can be translated as either "my spirit" or "my soul." In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on the soul's transition at death, "soul" might better capture the intended meaning in this deathbed prayer context.

[B] Or: "I despise those who observe empty vanities" — "Havlei-shav" (הַבְלֵי־שָׁוְא) could refer not just to literal idols but to any worthless or empty practices. A broader translation might better capture the range of meaningless pursuits contrasted with true faith in God.

[1] The original text uses the verb 'יתחיל' (begin) in the third person singular, following the instructional style common throughout Ma'avar Yabok, which provides directions to those caring for the sick and dying.

[2] This refers to the standardized opening prayer that begins each of the eight liturgical sequences in the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok. The 'etc.' (וגו׳) indicates that the reader should continue with the complete formula as previously specified.

[3] This phrase begins a collection of biblical verses from Torah that follow a pattern established throughout Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences, where verses are organized by their source (Torah, Prophets, Writings) to create comprehensive spiritual resources for healing.

[i] This refers to the standardized opening prayer formula that begins each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok. Rather than repeating the full text, the author simply refers readers back to where it first appears in Order 1.

[ii] This instruction provides options for which psalm to recite as part of the fourth order (Seder Dalet) of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok. The numbers refer to specific psalms that are considered especially appropriate for those who are ill.

[iii] This is the opening phrase of a prayer beginning with words from Deuteronomy 4:31. It continues a pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok of organizing prayers that begin with verses from Torah, followed by verses from Prophets, and then Writings.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder Section — This instruction for the fourth order demonstrates Ma'avar Yabok's systematic approach to prayer for the sick, creating a comprehensive yet flexible framework that allows for adaptation to different situations while maintaining a consistent structure. | Cf. Psalms 31, 38, 40, 71 — The selected psalms share themes of physical affliction, divine protection, and confidence in ultimate divine salvation—making them particularly appropriate for those experiencing serious illness. Their inclusion shows Ma'avar Yabok's careful curation of biblical texts as spiritual medicine. | Cf. Deuteronomy 4:31 — Beginning the prayer with this verse emphasizes God's compassionate nature even in times of suffering, setting a theological foundation that illness and judgment are ultimately expressions of divine love rather than abandonment.

וַאֲנִי אֶל־יְיָ בָּטַחְתִּי: אָגִילָה
וְאֶשְׂמְחָה בְּחַסְדֶּךָ אֲשֶׁר רָאִיתָ
אֶת־עָנְיִי יָדַעְתָּ בְּצָרוֹת נַפְשִׁי:
וְלֹא הִסְגַּרְתַּנִי בְיַד־אוֹיֵב הֶעֱמַדְתָּ
בַמֶּרְחָב רַגְלִי: חָנֵּנִי יְיָ כִּי צַר־לִי
עָשְׁשָׁה בְכַעַס עֵינִי נַפְשִׁי וּבִטְנִי:
כִּי כָלוּ בְיָגוֹן חַיַּי וּשְׁנוֹתַי בַּאֲנָחָה
כָּשַׁל בַּעֲוֹנִי כֹחִי וַעֲצָמַי עָשְׁשׁוּ:
מִכָּל־צוֹרְרַי הָיִיתִי חֶרְפָּה וְלִשְׁכֵנַי
מְאֹד וּפַחַד לְמְיָדְעָי רֹאַי בַּחוּץ
נָדְדוּ מִמֶּנִּי: נִשְׁכַּחְתִּי כְּמֵת מִלֵּב
הָיִיתִי כִּכְלִי אֹבֵד: כִּי שָׁמַעְתִּי דִּבַּת
רַבִּים מָגוֹר מִסָּבִיב בְּהִוָּסְדָם יַחַד
עָלַי לָקַחַת נַפְשִׁי זָמָמוּ: וַאֲנִי עָלֶיךָ
בָטַחְתִּי יְיָ אָמַרְתִּי אֱלֹהַי אָתָּה:
בְּיָדְךָ עִתֹּתָי הַצִּילֵנִי מִיַּד־אוֹיְבַי
וּמֵרֹדְפָי: הָאִירָה פָנֶיךָ עַל־עַבְדֶּךָ
הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי בְחַסְדֶּךָ: יְיָ אַל־אֵבוֹשָׁה
כִּי קְרָאתִיךָ יֵבשׁוּ רְשָׁעִים יִדְמוּ
לִשְׁאוֹל: תֵּאָלַמְנָה שִׂפְתֵי־שָׁקֶר
הַדֹּבְרוֹת עַל־צַדִּיק עָתָק בְּגַאֲוָה
וָבוּז: מָה רַב־טוּבְךָ אֲשֶׁר־צָפַנְתָּ
לִירֵאֶיךָ פָּעַלְתָּ לַחוֹסִים בָּךְ נֶגֶד
בְּנֵי אָדָם: תַּסְתִּירֵם בְּסֵתֶר פָּנֶיךָ
מֵרֶכֶס־אִישׁ[i] תִּצְפְּנֵם בְּסֻכָּה מֵרִיב
לְשֹׁנוֹת: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ כִּי הִפְלִיא חַסְדּוֹ
לִי בְּעִיר מָצוֹר[ii]: וַאֲנִי אָמַרְתִּי
בְחָפְזִי[iii] נִגְרַזְתִּי מִנֶּגֶד עֵינֶיךָ
אָכֵן שָׁמַעְתָּ קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנַי בְּשַׁוְּעִי
אֵלֶיךָ: אֱהֱבוּ אֶת־יְיָ כָּל־חֲסִידָיו
אֱמוּנִים נֹצֵר יְיָ וּמְשַׁלֵּם עַל־יֶתֶר

will rejoice and be glad in Your loving-kindness,[1] for
You have seen my affliction; You have known the
troubles of my soul. You have not delivered me into
the hand of the enemy; You have set my feet in a
broad place. Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am 770R
in distress; my eye is wasted with grief, as are my
soul and my body. For my life is spent in sorrow and
my years in sighing; my strength fails because of my
iniquity, and my bones waste away. I have become a
reproach to all my adversaries, exceedingly so to my 775R
neighbors, and a dread to my acquaintances; those
who see me outside flee from me. I am forgotten like
a dead person, out of mind; I have become like a
broken vessel. For I have heard the slander of many,
terror on every side; when they conspired together 780R
against me, they schemed to take my life. But I trust
in You, O LORD; I say, "You are my God." My times
are in Your hand; deliver me from the hand of my
enemies and from my pursuers. Make Your face shine
upon Your servant; save me in Your loving-kindness. 785R
O LORD, let me not be put to shame, for I have
called upon You; let the wicked be put to shame,
let them be silent in Sheol.[2] Let lying lips be mute,
which speak arrogantly against the righteous with
pride and contempt. How great is Your goodness, 790R
which You have stored up for those who fear You,
which You have performed for those who take refuge
in You before the sons of men. You hide them in the
shelter of Your presence[A] from the conspiracies of
man; You keep them secretly in a pavilion from the 795R
strife of tongues. Blessed be the LORD, for He has

[A] Or: "You conceal them in the secret place of Your face" — A more literal translation that preserves the striking Hebrew imagery of God's face having a "secret place" or "hiding place" where the faithful can take refuge.

[1] The psalm's movement from distress to confidence in divine mercy reflects Ma'avar Yabok's therapeutic approach to prayer for the sick, which typically progresses from acknowledging suffering to affirming trust in divine protection and healing.

[2] Sheol (שְׁאוֹל) refers to the abode of the dead in Hebrew Scripture. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this reference to the silence of the wicked in Sheol contrasts with the book's kabbalistic view that the righteous dead continue spiritual activities in the afterlife.

[i] The Hebrew term "merukhsei-ish" is somewhat obscure and has been variously interpreted. It likely refers to conspiracies, plots, or schemes of people against others. In the context of this psalm, it refers to human machinations against the righteous.

[ii] "In a besieged city" could be interpreted either literally (referring to David being surrounded by enemies in a physical city) or metaphorically (representing the psalmist's feeling of being surrounded by troubles and enemies on all sides).

[iii] The Hebrew term "b'chofzi" denotes a state of alarm, panic, or haste. It expresses the psalmist's emotional state when feeling cut off from divine protection.

עֹשֵׂה נִפְלָאוֹת[i]: חִזְקוּ וְיַאֲמֵץ לְבַבְכֶם
כָּל־הַמְיַחֲלִים לַיהוָה: [ii]

shown His wonderful loving-kindness to me in a besieged city. As for me, I said in my alarm, "I am cut off from before Your eyes." Nevertheless, You heard the voice of my supplications when I cried to You. 800R
Love the LORD, all His godly ones! The LORD preserves the faithful and fully repays the one who acts proudly. Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all you who hope in the LORD.

(תהלים לח) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד
לְהַזְכִּיר[iii]: יְיָ אַל־בְּקֶצְפְּךָ
740 תוֹכִיחֵנִי וּבַחֲמָתְךָ תְיַסְּרֵנִי:
כִּי־חִצֶּיךָ נְחָתוּ בִי[iv] וַתִּנָּחֵת עָלַי
יָדֶךָ: אֵין־מְתֹם בִּבְשָׂרִי[v] מִפְּנֵי
זַעְמֶךָ אֵין־שָׁלוֹם בַּעֲצָמַי מִפְּנֵי
חַטָּאתִי: כִּי עֲוֹנֹתַי עָבְרוּ רֹאשִׁי
745 כְּמַשָּׂא כָּבֵד יִכְבְּדוּ מִמֶּנִּי: הִבְאִישׁוּ
נָמַקּוּ חַבּוּרֹתָי[vi] מִפְּנֵי אִוַּלְתִּי:
נַעֲוֵיתִי שַׁחֹתִי עַד־מְאֹד כָּל־הַיּוֹם

(Psalm 38) A psalm of David, to bring to remembrance.[1] O LORD, do not rebuke me in Your anger, 805R
nor discipline me in Your wrath. For Your arrows have pierced me, and Your hand has come down upon me. There is no soundness in my flesh because of Your indignation; there is no peace in my bones be- 810R
cause of my sin. For my iniquities have gone over my head; like a heavy burden,[2] they are too heavy for me. My wounds grow foul and fester because of my foolishness. I am bent and bowed down greatly;[A] all

[A] Or: "I am twisted and brought very low" — The term נַעֲוֵיתִי has connotations of being twisted or distorted, which could better convey the extreme physical deformity that illness was believed to cause. This alternate translation might better capture the visceral nature of the suffering described in Ma'avar Yabok's context.

[1] This psalm appears in the fourth liturgical order (Seder Dalet) of Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of physical suffering attributed to sin, social isolation during illness, and urgent pleas for divine intervention make it particularly relevant for those experiencing serious illness.

[2] This psalm portrays sin as a crushing weight that manifests as physical illness, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework where suffering serves as divine correction for spiritual failings.

[i] This phrase is challenging to translate. It literally means "and repays in full to the one who acts with pride/arrogance." It contrasts the protection of the faithful with the punishment of the proud.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parshat Vayechi — Ma'avar Yabok draws on the Zohar's interpretation of "Into Your hand I commit my spirit" as the quintessential deathbed declaration, representing the soul's willing submission to divine custody at death. The book recommends this verse as a focus for meditation during the dying process. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder 4 — This psalm, particularly verse 6, is central to Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequence for the dying person. The book instructs attendants to help the dying recite this verse as their final words if possible, seeing it as the ideal expression of surrender to God at death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 5a — Ma'avar Yabok draws a parallel between sleep and death, both being times when one entrusts one's soul to divine keeping. The practice of reciting Psalm 31:6 before sleep prepares one for the ultimate surrender at death.

[iii] "To bring to remembrance" may refer to this psalm's use in memorial offerings or as a prayer to make God remember the supplicant in mercy. This connection to remembrance makes it particularly appropriate in Ma'avar Yabok's context, where it serves as a prayer for the sick seeking divine attention.

[iv] The metaphor of divine "arrows" piercing the body parallels Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of illness as divinely sent for spiritual correction rather than random misfortune.

[v] The Hebrew "ein metom" (no soundness/wholeness) is used twice in this psalm, emphasizing the totality of the physical affliction, which would resonate with the severely ill for whom Ma'avar Yabok was intended.

[vi] The graphic description of wounds becoming foul and festering uses verbs (הִבְאִישׁוּ "became putrid" and נָמַקּוּ "dissolve/decay") that would be particularly meaningful in the context of severe illness, connecting physical corruption with spiritual failings.

קֹדֶר הִלָּכְתִּי: כִּי־כִסְלַי מָלְאוּ
נִקְלֶה וְאֵין מְתֹם בִּבְשָׂרִי: נְפוּגוֹתִי
וְנִדְכֵּיתִי עַד־מְאֹד שָׁאַגְתִּי מִנַּהֲמַת
לִבִּי: אֲדֹנָי נֶגְדְּךָ כָל־תַּאֲוָתִי
וְאַנְחָתִי מִמְּךָ לֹא־נִסְתָּרָה: לִבִּי
סְחַרְחַר עֻזָּבַנִי כֹּחִי וְאוֹר־עֵינַי
גַּם־הֵם אֵין אִתִּי: אֹהֲבַי וְרֵעַי
מִנֶּגֶד נִגְעִי יַעֲמֹדוּ[i] וּקְרוֹבַי מֵרָחֹק
עָמָדוּ: וַיְנַקְּשׁוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי
וְדֹרְשֵׁי רָעָתִי דִּבְּרוּ הַוּוֹת וּמִרְמוֹת
כָּל־הַיּוֹם יֶהְגּוּ: וַאֲנִי כְחֵרֵשׁ לֹא
אֶשְׁמָע[ii] וּכְאִלֵּם לֹא יִפְתַּח־פִּיו:
וָאֱהִי כְּאִישׁ אֲשֶׁר לֹא־שֹׁמֵעַ
וְאֵין בְּפִיו תּוֹכָחוֹת: כִּי־לְךָ
יְיָ הוֹחָלְתִּי אַתָּה תַּעֲנֶה אֲדֹנָי
אֱלֹהָי: כִּי־אָמַרְתִּי פֶּן־יִשְׂמְחוּ־לִי
בְּמוֹט רַגְלִי עָלַי הִגְדִּילוּ: כִּי־אֲנִי
לְצֶלַע נָכוֹן[iii] וּמַכְאוֹבִי נֶגְדִּי
תָמִיד: כִּי־עֲוֹנִי אַגִּיד אֶדְאַג
מֵחַטָּאתִי: וְאֹיְבַי חַיִּים עָצְמוּ וְרַבּוּ
שֹׂנְאַי שָׁקֶר: וּמְשַׁלְּמֵי רָעָה תַּחַת
טוֹבָה יִשְׂטְנוּנִי תַּחַת (רדופי)
[רָדְפִי־]טוֹב: אַל־תַּעַזְבֵנִי יְיָ
אֱלֹהַי אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי: חוּשָׁה

day long I go about mourning.[1] For my loins are 815R
filled with burning, and there is no soundness in
my flesh. I am numb and utterly crushed;[A] I groan
because of the tumult of my heart.[B] O Lord, all my
longing is before You, and my sighing is not hidden
from You. My heart throbs, my strength fails me; 820R
and the light of my eyes—even that has gone from
me. My friends and companions stand aloof from
my affliction,[2] and my relatives stand far off. Those
who seek my life set traps, and those who seek my
harm speak of ruin, and meditate treachery all day 825R
long. But I am like a deaf man—I do not hear; like a
mute who does not open his mouth. I have become
like a man who does not hear, and in whose mouth
there are no arguments. For in You, O LORD, I
hope; You will answer, O Lord my God. For I said, 830R
"Lest they rejoice over me, when my foot slips, they
magnify themselves against me." For I am ready to
fall, and my pain is ever before me. For I will declare
my iniquity; I am anxious because of my sin. But my
enemies are vigorous and strong, and those who hate 835R
me wrongfully are numerous.[3] Those who repay evil
for good oppose me because I pursue what is good.
Do not forsake me, O LORD; O my God, do not

[A] Or: "I am grown cold and completely pulverized" — The term נְפוּגוֹתִי literally refers to growing cold or becoming numb, while נִדְכֵּיתִי suggests being crushed to powder. This more literal translation might better capture the physical sensation of life-force diminishing that would resonate with Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of the dying process.

[B] Or: "I roar from the groaning of my heart" — The verb שָׁאַגְתִּי literally means 'I roar' (like a lion), suggesting a more intense vocalization than merely groaning. This alternate translation conveys the visceral, almost animal-like suffering that severe illness can produce, which fits Ma'avar Yabok's realistic portrayal of the dying experience.

[1] The Hebrew term "koder" (קֹדֶר) conveys a state of being darkened or in shadow, suggesting both physical weakness and spiritual darkness—a dual condition that Ma'avar Yabok seeks to address through its integrated approach to physical and spiritual healing.

[2] The Hebrew term "nega" (נִגְעִי) for "affliction" can also refer specifically to a disease or plague, particularly those described in Leviticus. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this verse would be read as a critique of those who abandon the sick rather than fulfilling the mitzvah of visiting them.

[3] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these enemies might be interpreted both literally as human opponents and metaphorically as the spiritual forces or illness itself that afflicts the body. The book often portrays illness using martial imagery of battle against negative forces.

[i] This verse describing social isolation during illness reflects a reality often experienced by the severely ill, and contrasts with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper visitation of the sick as a sacred duty.

[ii] The psalmist's self-description as being like a deaf and mute person represents a posture of silent acceptance of divine judgment, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on accepting illness as divine correction.

[iii] The Hebrew "letzela nakhon" (ready to fall/limp) evokes physical frailty and the sense of being on the verge of collapse, a powerful expression of the precarious state between life and death that Ma'avar Yabok addresses.

לְעֶזְרָתִי אֲדֹנָי תְּשׁוּעָתִי׃[ii][i]

be far from me. Hasten to help me, O Lord, my salvation.[1] 840R

(תהלים מ) לַמְנַצֵּחַ לְדָוִד
מִזְמוֹר׃[iii] קַוֹּה קִוִּיתִי[iv] יְיָ וַיֵּט
אֵלַי וַיִּשְׁמַע שַׁוְעָתִי׃ וַיַּעֲלֵנִי
מִבּוֹר שָׁאוֹן מִטִּיט הַיָּוֵן[v] וַיָּקֶם
עַל־סֶלַע רַגְלַי כּוֹנֵן אֲשֻׁרָי׃ וַיִּתֵּן
בְּפִי שִׁיר חָדָשׁ תְּהִלָּה לֵאלֹהֵינוּ
יִרְאוּ רַבִּים וְיִירָאוּ וְיִבְטְחוּ
בַּיהוָה׃ אַשְׁרֵי הַגֶּבֶר אֲשֶׁר־שָׂם
יְיָ מִבְטַחוֹ וְלֹא־פָנָה אֶל־רְהָבִים
וְשָׂטֵי כָזָב׃ רַבּוֹת עָשִׂיתָ אַתָּה

(Psalm 40) For the choir director. A psalm of David. I waited patiently for the LORD; He inclined to me and heard my cry. He lifted me out of the pit of destruction, from the miry clay,[A] and set my feet upon a rock, making my steps secure.[2] He put a new song in my mouth, a hymn of praise to our God; many will see and fear and trust in the LORD.[3] Blessed is the man who makes the LORD his trust, who does not turn to the proud or to those who follow falsehood.[4] Many, O LORD my 845R 850R

[A] Or: "He brought me up from the pit of tumultuous noise, from the muddy mire" — This alternate translation preserves the acoustic dimension of 'sha'on' (שָׁאוֹן) which includes the sense of roaring noise or tumult, and might better capture the chaotic experience of serious illness that the psalm metaphorically describes.

[1] The psalm's conclusion with this direct invocation of God as the source of salvation reflects Ma'avar Yabok's central theological premise that true healing comes ultimately from God, even when human medical intervention is employed.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'konen ashurai' (כּוֹנֵן אֲשֻׁרָי) conveys not just stability but divinely established direction. For those using this psalm during illness, it offers hope of both physical recovery and spiritual reorientation.

[3] This suggests that the individual's healing becomes a public testimony that benefits the broader community. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this reflects how proper spiritual care for the sick can have wider spiritual impact beyond the individual.

[4] The Hebrew terms 'rehavim' (רְהָבִים) and 'satei kazav' (שָׂטֵי כָזָב) refer to those who trust in false powers or deceptive remedies. In the context of illness, this warns against seeking healing through spiritually questionable means rather than divine assistance.

[i] The psalm concludes with an urgent plea for divine assistance, using the word "teshuat" (salvation), which encompasses both physical healing and spiritual deliverance—perfectly aligned with Ma'avar Yabok's holistic approach to illness.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Siftei Tzedek — Psalm 38's description of friends and relatives standing aloof from the sufferer (verses 11-12) would be read as a warning in Ma'avar Yabok's context, reinforcing the book's emphasis on proper visitation of the sick (bikur cholim) as a sacred obligation. | Cf. Zohar — Psalm 38's attribution of physical suffering to divine judgment aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework from the Zohar, where illness serves as spiritual correction rather than mere punishment. This psalm's theological perspective would be interpreted within Ma'avar Yabok's larger framework where suffering serves to purify the soul. | Cf. Job — Unlike Job, who maintains his innocence despite suffering, Psalm 38 acknowledges sin as the cause of affliction. Ma'avar Yabok integrates both perspectives, recognizing that while suffering often results from spiritual failings, proper response through confession and prayer (as modeled in this psalm) can transform suffering into spiritual elevation.

[iii] The superscription 'For the choir director. A psalm of David' establishes this as one of the psalms intended for Temple worship. The term 'lamnatze'ach' (לַמְנַצֵּחַ) literally means 'for the one who overcomes' and became a technical term for the Temple choir director.

[iv] This opening phrase employs a Hebrew grammatical form called the 'infinitive absolute' followed by the finite verb of the same root (קוה), creating a sense of emphatic waiting or expectation. This construction intensifies the action, conveying 'I waited intensely' or 'I waited with complete patience.'

[v] These powerful metaphors describe a life-threatening situation: 'bor sha'on' (pit of destruction/tumult) suggests both physical danger and spiritual chaos, while 'tit hayaven' (miry clay) evokes being trapped in a substance from which one cannot escape without help. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these metaphors would be understood as referring to serious illness and its spiritual dimensions.

יְיָ אֱלֹהַי נִפְלְאֹתֶיךָ וּמַחְשְׁבֹתֶיךָ
אֵלֵינוּ אֵין עֵרֶךָ אֵלֶיךָ אַגִּידָה
וַאֲדַבְּרָה עָצְמוּ מִסַּפֵּר: זֶבַח
וּמִנְחָה לֹא־חָפַצְתָּ אָזְנַיִם כָּרִיתָ
לִי[i] עוֹלָה וַחֲטָאָה לֹא שָׁאָלְתָּ: אָז
אָמַרְתִּי הִנֵּה־בָאתִי בִּמְגִלַּת־סֵפֶר
כָּתוּב עָלָי: לַעֲשׂוֹת־רְצוֹנְךָ
אֱלֹהַי חָפָצְתִּי וְתוֹרָתְךָ בְּתוֹךְ
מֵעָי[ii]: בִּשַּׂרְתִּי צֶדֶק בְּקָהָל רָב
הִנֵּה שְׂפָתַי לֹא אֶכְלָא יְיָ אַתָּה
יָדָעְתָּ: צִדְקָתְךָ לֹא־כִסִּיתִי בְּתוֹךְ
לִבִּי אֱמוּנָתְךָ וּתְשׁוּעָתְךָ אָמָרְתִּי
לֹא־כִחַדְתִּי חַסְדְּךָ וַאֲמִתְּךָ לְקָהָל
רָב: אַתָּה יְיָ לֹא־תִכְלָא רַחֲמֶיךָ
מִמֶּנִּי חַסְדְּךָ וַאֲמִתְּךָ תָּמִיד יִצְּרוּנִי:
כִּי אָפְפוּ־עָלַי רָעוֹת עַד־אֵין
מִסְפָּר הִשִּׂיגוּנִי עֲוֹנֹתַי וְלֹא־יָכֹלְתִּי
לִרְאוֹת עָצְמוּ מִשַּׂעֲרוֹת רֹאשִׁי
וְלִבִּי עֲזָבָנִי[iii]: רְצֵה יְיָ לְהַצִּילֵנִי
יְיָ לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה: יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ
יַחַד מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי לִסְפּוֹתָהּ יִסֹּגוּ
אָחוֹר וְיִכָּלְמוּ חֲפֵצֵי רָעָתִי: יָשֻׁמּוּ
עַל־עֵקֶב בָּשְׁתָּם הָאֹמְרִים לִי
הֶאָח הֶאָח[iv]: יָשִׂישׂוּ וְיִשְׂמְחוּ בְךָ
כָּל־מְבַקְשֶׁיךָ יֹאמְרוּ תָמִיד יִגְדַּל יְיָ
אֹהֲבֵי תְּשׁוּעָתֶךָ: וַאֲנִי עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן

God, are the wonders You have done, and Your thoughts toward us cannot be recounted to You—if I would declare and speak of them, they are too numerous to count.[A] Sacrifice and offering You did not desire; my ears You have opened.[B][1] Burnt offering and sin offering You did not require. Then I said, "Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written about me. I delight to do Your will, my God; Your law is within my heart." I have proclaimed righteousness in the great assembly; behold, I have not restrained my lips, O LORD, You know. I have not hidden Your righteousness within my heart; I have spoken of Your faithfulness and Your salvation; I have not concealed Your lovingkindness and Your truth from the great assembly. You, O LORD, will not withhold Your compassion from me; Your lovingkindness and Your truth will continually preserve me. For evils beyond number have surrounded me; my iniquities have overtaken me, and I cannot see.[2] They are more numerous than the hairs of my head, and my heart has failed me. Be pleased, O LORD, to deliver me; O LORD, hasten to help me. May those who seek to take my life be ashamed and confounded together; may those who desire my harm be driven backward and humiliated. May those who say to me, "Aha!

855R 860R 865R 870R 875R

[A] Or: "they have become too mighty to recount" — The Hebrew 'atzmu' (עָצְמוּ) carries connotations of strength and might, not just numerical quantity. This alternative captures the overwhelming power of God's wonders, not merely their number.

[B] Or: "ears You have dug for me" — This more literal translation of the Hebrew verb 'karita' (כָּרִיתָ) captures the physical imagery of excavation or digging, which some commentators interpret as referring to God creating receptivity in the psalmist.

[1] This verse is crucial to understanding Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death and illness. While the book details many rituals and prayers, it consistently emphasizes that external observances are meaningless without interior spiritual preparation—receptive ears and an obedient heart.

[2] The psalmist's acknowledgment of overwhelming sin connects to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of illness as potentially related to spiritual failings, requiring confession (vidui) as part of the healing process.

[i] This phrase literally means 'ears You have dug for me,' which has been interpreted in various ways. It may refer to the creation of the ears, to making the psalmist receptive to divine instruction, or (as in some ancient translations) to the preparation of a body. The emphasis is on God creating receptivity to divine will rather than desiring external sacrifices.

[ii] The phrase 'Your Torah is within my inner parts' uses the Hebrew 'me'ai' (מֵעַי), which literally refers to the intestines or internal organs. This visceral image depicts internalization of divine teaching at the deepest physical level, not merely intellectual acceptance.

[iii] The expression 'my heart has failed me' (literally 'my heart has abandoned me') poignantly describes both physical weakness and emotional despair, making this psalm particularly relevant for those with serious illness where both physical and emotional suffering occur simultaneously.

[iv] The Hebrew expression 'he'ach he'ach' (הֶאָח הֶאָח) is an exclamation of malicious delight at another's misfortune. This double repetition emphasizes the cruelty of those who mock the suffering person.

אֲדֹנָי יַחְשָׁב־לִי עֻזָּרְתִי וּמְפַלְטִי
810 אַתָּה אֱלֹהַי אַל־תְּאַחַר׃ [i]

Aha!" be appalled because of their shame. May all who seek You rejoice and be glad in You; may those who love Your salvation say continually, "The LORD be magnified!" But I am poor and needy; 880R may the Lord consider me.[1] You are my help and my deliverer; O my God, do not delay.

(תהלים מא) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר
לְדָוִד׃ אַשְׁרֵי מַשְׂכִּיל אֶל־דָּל [ii] בְּיוֹם
רָעָה יְמַלְּטֵהוּ יְיָ׃ יְיָ יִשְׁמְרֵהוּ
וִיחַיֵּהוּ (יאשר) [וְאֻשַּׁר]
815 בָּאָרֶץ וְאַל־תִּתְּנֵהוּ בְּנֶפֶשׁ
אֹיְבָיו׃ יְיָ יִסְעָדֶנּוּ עַל־עֶרֶשׂ
דְּוָי [iii] כָּל־מִשְׁכָּבוֹ הָפַכְתָּ
בְחָלְיוֹ [iv]׃ אֲנִי־אָמַרְתִּי יְיָ חָנֵּנִי

(Psalm 41) For the chief musician. A psalm of David. Happy is one who considers the poor;[A] in the day of trouble, the LORD will deliver him. The LORD will 885R preserve him and keep him alive; he shall be blessed in the land, and You will not deliver him to the will of his enemies. The LORD will sustain him on his sickbed;[2] You will transform his entire bed during his illness.[B] I said, "LORD, be gracious to me; heal my 890R

[A] Or: "Blessed is one who acts wisely toward the afflicted" — This alternative emphasizes the intellectual discernment (from the root s-k-l) needed when caring for the sick, and broadens "dal" to include all afflicted people, not just the economically poor. This interpretation would better align with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on proper care for the ill.

[B] Or: "You completely change his condition in his illness" — The Hebrew "mishkav" (bed) can also refer metaphorically to one's condition or situation. This interpretation suggests that God fundamentally transforms the sick person's entire state, which aligns with the kabbalistic view of illness as potentially transformative rather than merely punitive.

[1] The psalm concludes with humble acknowledgment of dependence on divine help, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on humility and surrender as the proper spiritual stance when facing illness or approaching death.

[2] This verse forms a cornerstone of Jewish teachings on visiting the sick (bikur cholim). The psalm creates a spiritual reciprocity: those who care for others in illness will themselves be cared for by God should they become ill.

[i] Cf. Psalm 70 — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section is significant as it combines themes of divine rescue from death-like circumstances with an urgent plea for immediate help. The psalm's dual nature—thanksgiving for past deliverance followed by urgent petition for present troubles—makes it particularly appropriate for the sick who might reflect on past healings while seeking present relief. | Cf. Hebrews 10:5-7 — While Ma'avar Yabok would not directly reference Christian interpretations, this psalm's emphasis on interior devotion over external sacrifice aligns with the work's focus on sincere spiritual preparation for death over mere ritual observance. | Cf. Zohar III:216b — Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework would interpret the 'pit' metaphor as representing both physical illness and spiritual descent, with the psalm offering hope that God can rescue even from these depths. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim 40:2 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm would be understood as describing not just physical rescue but spiritual purification from sin, which aligns with the book's emphasis on confession and repentance during illness.

[ii] The Hebrew phrase "maskil el-dal" has layers of meaning beyond simply "considers the poor." It suggests giving thoughtful attention (from the root s-k-l, to understand or be wise) to the needy or afflicted. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would refer specifically to tending to the sick as a form of spiritual wisdom.

[iii] The phrase "eres devai" (bed of illness) is significant in Ma'avar Yabok as it directly relates to the book's focus on care for the bedridden sick. This verse was particularly important in Jewish traditions around visiting the sick (bikur cholim).

[iv] The Hebrew "You have transformed his entire bed in his illness" is ambiguous and has been interpreted in several ways in rabbinic tradition: 1) God transforms the sick person's suffering into comfort; 2) God assists in turning the patient's bedding for comfort; or 3) the illness completely transforms the person's experience of rest. This verse was central to Jewish teachings about divine involvement in healing.

רְפָאָה נַפְשִׁי כִּי־חָטָאתִי לָךְ׃[i]
אוֹיְבַי יֹאמְרוּ רַע לִי מָתַי יָמוּת
וְאָבַד שְׁמוֹ׃ וְאִם־בָּא לִרְאוֹת שָׁוְא
יְדַבֵּר[ii] לִבּוֹ יִקְבָּץ־אָוֶן לוֹ יֵצֵא
לַחוּץ יְדַבֵּר׃ יַחַד עָלַי יִתְלַחֲשׁוּ
כָּל־שֹׂנְאָי עָלַי יַחְשְׁבוּ רָעָה לִי׃
דְּבַר־בְּלִיַּעַל יָצוּק בּוֹ[iii] וַאֲשֶׁר
שָׁכַב לֹא־יוֹסִיף לָקוּם׃ גַּם־אִישׁ
שְׁלוֹמִי[iv] אֲשֶׁר־בָּטַחְתִּי בּוֹ אוֹכֵל
לַחְמִי הִגְדִּיל עָלַי עָקֵב׃ וְאַתָּה
יְיָ חָנֵּנִי וַהֲקִימֵנִי וַאֲשַׁלְּמָה לָהֶם׃
בְּזֹאת יָדַעְתִּי כִּי־חָפַצְתָּ בִּי כִּי
לֹא־יָרִיעַ אוֹיְבִי עָלָי׃ וַאֲנִי בְּתֻמִּי
תָּמַכְתָּ בִּי וַתַּצִּיבֵנִי לְפָנֶיךָ לְעוֹלָם׃
בָּרוּךְ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵהָעוֹלָם
וְעַד הָעוֹלָם אָמֵן וְאָמֵן׃[v]

soul, for I have sinned against You."[1] My enemies speak evil of me, saying, "When will he die and his name perish?" And if one comes to visit, he speaks falsely;[2] his heart gathers wickedness to itself, then he goes outside and speaks it. All who hate me whisper together against me; against me they devise harm for me. "A wicked thing is poured into him,[A] and now that he lies down, he will rise no more." Even my close friend in whom I trusted, who ate my bread, has lifted up his heel against me.[3] But You, O LORD, be gracious to me and raise me up, that I may repay them. By this I know that You delight in me: that my enemy does not triumph over me. As for me, You uphold me in my integrity and set me before Your presence forever. Blessed be the LORD, God of Israel,[4] from everlasting to everlasting. Amen and

[A] Or: "An incurable disease clings to him" — Based on rabbinic interpretations that view "devar-beliyaal" as referring specifically to a fatal illness. This reading would be more specific to Ma'avar Yabok's context of serious illness, though it's more interpretive than literal.

[1] This reflects the Jewish understanding that illness often requires both physical and spiritual healing. The psalmist's focus on healing the soul first aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on spiritual preparation during illness.

[2] The psalm contrasts proper visitation of the sick with improper visitation characterized by false speech and harmful intentions. Ma'avar Yabok would have included this psalm partly to instruct readers on proper versus improper behavior when visiting the ill.

[3] This expression of betrayal by a close friend would have special resonance for the seriously ill who might experience abandonment by friends and family. The psalm validates these feelings while still expressing ultimate trust in divine support.

[4] This doxology (blessing formula) actually marks the end of Book I of Psalms (Psalms 1-41) rather than being part of the original psalm. Its inclusion in prayer sequences for the sick would have added a formal liturgical closing to the recitation.

[i] This verse reflects the traditional Jewish understanding that illness could be connected to sin, and that healing required both physical and spiritual remedies. The request to "heal my soul" emphasizes spiritual healing as primary, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework.

[ii] This describes insincere visitation of the sick, where someone comes with false pretenses. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this passage would underscore the importance of proper intention when visiting the sick, contrasting false visitors with those who truly care for the ill person's wellbeing.

[iii] The phrase "devar-beliyaal yatzuk bo" literally means "a thing of Belial is poured into him," where Belial represents wickedness or worthlessness. This was interpreted in rabbinic tradition as referring to a fatal illness or condition that has taken hold of the person, rendering recovery impossible in the eyes of enemies.

[iv] "Ish shelomi" (literally "man of my peace/welfare") refers to a close friend or confidant. The betrayal described here would have resonated with the sick who sometimes experienced abandonment by friends during serious illness, making this psalm particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of proper care for the dying.

[v] Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok likely included Psalm 41 in its prayer sequences because of the Zohar's interpretation that this psalm specifically relates to the spiritual dimensions of illness and the merit of those who properly visit and care for the sick. | Cf. Talmud — Ma'avar Yabok would have incorporated this psalm into its prayer sequences based on this Talmudic interpretation that visiting the sick has actual healing power and that God responds to proper visitation by supporting the ill person. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The inclusion of this psalm in a prayer sequence reinforces the book's earlier teachings about bikur cholim (visiting the sick), creating an integrated approach where theoretical teachings are supported by specific prayers and psalms to be recited during such visits.

Amen.

(תורה) כִּי אֵל רַחוּם יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ
לֹא יַרְפְּךָ וְלֹא יַשְׁחִיתֶךָ וְלֹא יִשְׁכַּח
אֶת בְּרִית אֲבֹתֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע לָהֶם:
וְאַתֶּם הַדְּבֵקִים בַּיהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם
חַיִּים כֻּלְּכֶם הַיּוֹם:[i] וַיִּנָּחֶם יְהוָה
עַל הָרָעָה[ii] אֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר לַעֲשׂוֹת
לְעַמּוֹ: אַתָּה הָרְאֵתָ לָדַעַת כִּי
יְהוָה הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים אֵין עוֹד
מִלְבַדּוֹ:[iii] וְיָדַעְתָּ הַיּוֹם וַהֲשֵׁבֹתָ
אֶל לְבָבֶךָ כִּי יְהוָה הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים
בַּשָּׁמַיִם מִמַּעַל וְעַל הָאָרֶץ מִתָּחַת
אֵין עוֹד: וְיָדַעְתָּ כִּי יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ
הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים הָאֵל הַנֶּאֱמָן שֹׁמֵר
הַבְּרִית וְהַחֶסֶד לְאֹהֲבָיו וּלְשֹׁמְרֵי
מִצְוֹתָיו לְאֶלֶף דּוֹר:[iv]

(Torah) For the LORD your God is a merciful God;[1] He will not abandon you or destroy you, and He will not forget the covenant of your ancestors that He swore to them. And you who cling to the LORD your God are all alive today. And the LORD relented concerning the harm which He had spoken of doing to His people. You have been shown, in order to know, that the LORD is God; there is none besides Him.[2] Know therefore today, and take it to your heart, that the LORD is God in heaven above and on the earth below; there is none else. And you shall know that the LORD your God, He is God, the faithful God who keeps covenant and loving-kindness with those who love Him and keep His commandments, to a thousand generations.[3]

(נביאים)[v] וְאָמַר בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא
הִנֵּה אֱלֹהֵינוּ זֶה קִוִּינוּ לוֹ

(Prophets) And it shall be said on that day, "Behold, this is our God for whom we have waited, and He will

[1]This collection of verses is labeled '(Torah)' to indicate they come from the Pentateuch, following Ma'avar Yabok's pattern of organizing healing verses by their scriptural source (Torah, Prophets, and Writings).

[2]This phrase appears in Ma'avar Yabok's list of specific healing formulas and was considered particularly powerful when recited with proper intention. The repetition of this concept three times in this verse collection (with slight variations) would have been seen as spiritually significant.

[3]These verses appear in the fourth liturgical order (Seder Dalet) of Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer sequences for the sick. They establish God's mercy, covenant faithfulness, and absolute sovereignty—theological foundations that frame illness as ultimately subject to divine control and potentially reversible through proper prayer.

[i]The Hebrew verb דבק (to cleave/cling) has mystical significance in kabbalistic thought, describing the ideal state of attachment between the human soul and God. In the context of illness, this verse suggests that spiritual attachment to God is connected to physical vitality.

[ii]The concept of God "relenting" from harm is particularly significant in a healing context, as it provides biblical precedent for the possibility that divine decrees of illness might be reversed through proper prayer.

[iii]This phrase "there is none besides Him" appears elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as a specific healing formula to be recited for "strange illnesses." Its inclusion in this collection of verses emphasizes its perceived therapeutic power.

[iv]Cf. Deuteronomy 4:31 — This verse emphasizes God's mercy and covenant faithfulness, which would be especially relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and suffering. It offers reassurance that God will not abandon the sufferer, even in their distress. | Cf. Deuteronomy 4:4 — This verse connects physical life with spiritual attachment to God. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would suggest that clinging to God spiritually is a path to life, even when physically threatened by illness. | Cf. Exodus 32:14 — This verse about God relenting from punishment offers hope that divine decrees of illness might also be reversed through proper prayer and repentance, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Deuteronomy 4:35, 4:39-40 — These verses emphasize absolute divine unity and sovereignty, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context would reinforce that illness and healing are ultimately in God's hands alone. The phrase 'there is none besides Him' (אין עוד מלבדו) is specifically mentioned in Ma'avar Yabok as a powerful healing formula.

[v]This indicates that the following verses come from the Prophets section of the Hebrew Bible (Nevi'im), the second major division of the Tanakh. In Ma'avar Yabok, biblical verses are often organized by their source (Torah, Prophets, Writings) to create structured healing prayers.

וְיֹשִׁיעֵנוּ זֶה יְהוָה קִוִּינוּ לוֹ
נָגִילָה וְנִשְׂמְחָה בִּישׁוּעָתוֹ: בַּלַּע
הַמָּוֶת לָנֶצַח [i] וּמָחָה אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה
דִּמְעָה מֵעַל כָּל פָּנִים וְחֶרְפַּת
עַמּוֹ יָסִיר מֵעַל כָּל הָאָרֶץ כִּי
יְהוָה דִּבֶּר: וְלָכֵן יְחַכֶּה יְהוָה
לַחֲנַנְכֶם וְלָכֵן יָרוּם לְרַחֶמְכֶם כִּי
אֱלֹהֵי מִשְׁפָּט יְהוָה אַשְׁרֵי כָּל חוֹכֵי
לוֹ: וּפְדוּיֵי יְהוָה יְשֻׁבוּן [ii] וּבָאוּ
צִיּוֹן בְּרִנָּה וְשִׂמְחַת עוֹלָם עַל
רֹאשָׁם שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה יַשִּׂיגוּ וְנָסוּ
יָגוֹן וַאֲנָחָה: וָאֲשִׂים דְּבָרַי בְּפִיךָ
וּבְצֵל יָדִי כִּסִּיתִיךָ לִנְטֹעַ שָׁמַיִם
וְלִיסֹד אֶרֶץ וְלֵאמֹר לְצִיּוֹן עַמִּי
אָתָּה: אַל תִּירְאִי כִּי לֹא תֵבוֹשִׁי
וְאַל תִּכָּלְמִי כִּי לֹא תַחְפִּירִי כִּי
בֹשֶׁת עֲלוּמַיִךְ תִּשְׁכָּחִי וְחֶרְפַּת
אַלְמְנוּתַיִךְ לֹא תִזְכְּרִי עוֹד: כִּרֵעַ
קָטֹן עֲזַבְתִּיךְ וּבְרַחֲמִים גְּדֹלִים
אֲקַבְּצֵךְ: [iii] בְּשֶׁצֶף קֶצֶף הִסְתַּרְתִּי

save us. This is the LORD for whom we have waited; 925R
let us rejoice and be glad in His salvation." He will
swallow up death forever,[1] and the Lord GOD will
wipe away tears from all faces, and the reproach of
His people He will remove from all the earth, for
the LORD has spoken. Therefore the LORD will 930R
wait to be gracious to you, and therefore He will
rise up to show mercy to you. For the LORD is a
God of justice; blessed are all those who wait for
Him.[2] And the redeemed of the LORD shall return
and come to Zion with singing,[A] and everlasting joy 935R
shall be upon their heads; they shall obtain gladness
and joy, and sorrow and sighing shall flee away.[3] "I
have put My words in your mouth and covered you
in the shadow of My hand, to establish the heavens
and to found the earth,[4] and to say to Zion, 'You are 940R
My people.'" Fear not, for you will not be ashamed;
neither be confounded, for you will not be disgraced.
For you will forget the shame of your youth, and
the reproach of your widowhood you will remember

[A] Or: "And those ransomed by the LORD shall return and enter Zion with joyful shouting" — This alternate translation emphasizes the act of divine ransoming (פדה carries connotations of paying a redemption price) and captures the exuberant nature of רִנָּה, which is more than just singing but jubilant, triumphant exclamation. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this might better convey the soul's victorious journey after being ransomed from suffering.

[1] This powerful messianic prophecy is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on the transition between life and death. The Hebrew verb בִּלַּע (bila) carries connotations of complete consumption or elimination, suggesting not just the end of death but its total absorption into divine power.

[2] The Hebrew term חוֹכֵי (chochei) for 'those who wait' carries connotations of hopeful anticipation rather than passive waiting. In the context of illness, this blessing on those who wait suggests that patient endurance of suffering while maintaining hope for divine intervention is itself a spiritually meritorious state.

[3] The Hebrew phrase וְנָסוּ יָגוֹן וַאֲנָחָה uses the verb נָסוּ (nasu, 'they shall flee') to personify sorrow and sighing as enemies that will be driven away. This vivid imagery of negative emotions actively fleeing creates a powerful contrast with the enduring joy that replaces them.

[4] This cosmic language about establishing heavens and founding earth connects human speech and divine protection to the very creation of the universe. In Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that proper prayers for healing participate in the ongoing divine work of sustaining creation.

[i] This powerful phrase about God swallowing up death forever comes from Isaiah 25:8 and represents one of the most explicit statements in the Hebrew Bible about the ultimate elimination of death. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse transforms the immediate experience of mortality into a temporary state within a larger divine plan.

[ii] This phrase about 'the redeemed of the LORD' returning begins Isaiah 35:10, which describes the joyful return of exiles to Zion. In Ma'avar Yabok, this national redemption imagery is repurposed to describe the soul's journey after death as a form of spiritual homecoming.

[iii] This poignant verse from Isaiah 54:7 uses the metaphor of God as husband and Israel as wife, describing a brief abandonment followed by compassionate reconciliation. In the context of illness, it reframes suffering as a temporary divine withdrawal that will be followed by even greater compassion.

פָּנַי רֶגַע מִמֵּךְ וּבְחֶסֶד עוֹלָם
רִחַמְתִּיךְ אָמַר גֹּאֲלֵךְ יְהוָה: אָז
יִבָּקַע כַּשַּׁחַר אוֹרֵךְ וַאֲרֻכָתֵךְ מְהֵרָה
875 תִצְמָח[i] וְהָלַךְ לְפָנֶיךָ צִדְקֵךְ כְּבוֹד
יְהוָה יַאַסְפֶךָ: אָז תִּקְרָא וַיהוָה
יַעֲנֶה תְּשַׁוַּע וְיֹאמַר הִנֵּנִי אִם תָּסִיר
מִתּוֹכְךָ מוֹטָה שִׁלַּח אֶצְבַּע וְדֹבֶר
אָוֶן: תַּחַת הַנַּעֲצוּץ יַעֲלֶה בְרוֹשׁ
880 וְתַחַת הַסִּרְפָּד יַעֲלֶה הֲדַס[ii] וְהָיָה
לַיהוָה לְשֵׁם לְאוֹת עוֹלָם לֹא
יִכָּרֵת: בּוֹרֵא נִיב שְׂפָתָיִם שָׁלוֹם
שָׁלוֹם לָרָחוֹק וְלַקָּרוֹב[iii] אָמַר
יְהוָה וּרְפָאתִיו: [iv]

no more.[1] "For a brief moment I forsook you, but 945R
with great compassion I will gather you.[A] In a flood
of anger I hid My face from you for a moment, but
with everlasting kindness I will have compassion on
you," says the LORD, your Redeemer. Then your
light shall break forth like the dawn, and your healing 950R
shall spring up quickly;[B] your righteousness shall go
before you, and the glory of the LORD shall be your
rear guard. Then you shall call, and the LORD will
answer; you shall cry, and He will say, 'Here I am.' If
you remove the yoke from your midst, the pointing 955R
of the finger, and speaking wickedness. Instead of
the thorn shall come up the cypress, and instead of

[A] Or: "For a mere instant I abandoned you, but with abundant mercies I will collect you" — This alternative emphasizes the extreme brevity of רֶגַע קָטֹן (literally 'small moment') and the plurality of רַחֲמִים (mercies/compassions), which derives from the Hebrew word for 'womb' and suggests motherly tenderness. The verb אֲקַבְּצֵךְ (I will collect/gather) can have connotations of bringing scattered parts back together, which might be relevant in the context of illness where one feels 'scattered' or fragmented.

[B] Or: "Then your light shall burst forth like the morning, and your recovery shall speedily flourish" — This alternate translation captures the forceful nature of יִבָּקַע (to burst, break open with force) and the organic, growth-oriented imagery of תִצְמָח (to sprout, flourish, grow). The term אַרֻכָתֵךְ specifically refers to physical recovery or healing of wounds, which is important in the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] The metaphor of widowhood (אַלְמְנוּתַיִךְ) draws on the common biblical portrayal of Israel as God's bride, with periods of divine absence described as widowhood. In the context of illness and approaching death, this suggests that the current experience of spiritual abandonment will be replaced by a renewed divine relationship where previous suffering is forgotten.

[i] This verse from Isaiah 58:8 explicitly connects light with healing (אַרֻכָתֵךְ, literally 'your healing'). The imagery of healing 'sprouting quickly' uses botanical metaphors to suggest that recovery can manifest suddenly, like plants breaking through soil at dawn.

[ii] This verse from Isaiah 55:13 uses botanical transformation (thorns becoming cypress trees, briers becoming myrtles) as a metaphor for redemptive change. In Ma'avar Yabok, this imagery suggests that the suffering of illness will ultimately be replaced by spiritual beauty and fragrance.

[iii] This phrase from Isaiah 57:19 literally means 'creating the fruit/utterance of lips,' referring to divinely inspired speech. The repetition of 'peace, peace' (שָׁלוֹם שָׁלוֹם) intensifies the concept, while 'far and near' suggests universal application. In the context of healing prayers, it suggests that properly directed speech itself has creative power.

[iv] Cf. Isaiah 25:9 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves as a powerful statement of faith and hope, transforming the experience of illness or approaching death into an anticipated divine encounter where suffering will end and salvation will arrive. | Cf. Isaiah 25:8 — This reference provides profound comfort for the dying and their attendants by reframing death as a temporary state that will eventually be overcome by divine power. The verse transforms the immediate experience of mortality into a transitional phase within a larger divine plan. | Cf. Isaiah 30:18 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse reframes divine patience as an expression of compassion rather than abandonment, encouraging the sick to await divine mercy with trust rather than despair. | Cf. Isaiah 35:10 — This verse is repurposed in Ma'avar Yabok to depict the soul's journey after death as a form of redemption and homecoming, comparing death to exile and the afterlife to a joyful return to one's spiritual source. | Cf. Isaiah 51:16 — In the context of illness and approaching death, this verse reassures the sick person that they remain under divine protection ('shadow of My hand') and retain cosmic significance even in their weakened state. | Cf. Isaiah 54:4-8 — In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses reframe illness as a temporary divine withdrawal that will be followed by compassionate restoration, using the metaphor of marital reconciliation to describe the divine-human relationship even through suffering. | Cf. Isaiah 58:8-9 — In the context of Ma'avar

the brier shall come up the myrtle. And it shall be to the LORD for a name, for an everlasting sign that shall not be cut off. "Creating the fruit of the lips: 960R
Peace, peace, to the far and to the near," says the LORD, "and I will heal him."[1]

885 (כתובים) נַפְשֵׁנוּ חִכְּתָה לַיהוָה
עֶזְרֵנוּ וּמָגִנֵּנוּ הוּא: כִּי בוֹ יִשְׂמַח
לִבֵּנוּ כִּי בְשֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ בָּטָחְנוּ: יְהִי
חַסְדְּךָ יְהוָה עָלֵינוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר יִחַלְנוּ
לָךְ: פּוֹדֶה יְהוָה נֶפֶשׁ עֲבָדָיו וְלֹא
890 יֶאְשְׁמוּ כָּל הַחֹסִים בּוֹ: וְנַפְשִׁי
תָּגִיל בַּיהוָה תָּשִׂישׂ בִּישׁוּעָתוֹ:
כָּל עַצְמוֹתַי תֹּאמַרְנָה יְהוָה מִי
כָמוֹךָ מַצִּיל עָנִי מֵחָזָק מִמֶּנּוּ וְעָנִי
וְאֶבְיוֹן מִגֹּזְלוֹ: כִּי עִמְּךָ מְקוֹר
895 חַיִּים בְּאוֹרְךָ נִרְאֶה אוֹר: מְשֹׁךְ
יָקָר חַסְדְּךָ אֱלֹהִים וּבְנֵי אָדָם
בְּצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ יֶחֱסָיוּן: וְהִתְעַנֵּג
עַל יְהוָה וְיִתֶּן לְךָ מִשְׁאֲלֹת לִבֶּךָ:

Our soul waits for the LORD;[2] He is our help and our shield. For in Him our heart rejoices, for in His holy name we have trusted.[A] May Your lovingkind- 965R
ness, O LORD, be upon us, according as we have hoped in You. The LORD redeems the soul of His servants, and none who take refuge in Him will be condemned.[B] And my soul shall exult in the LORD; it shall rejoice in His salvation. All my bones shall 970R
say,[3] "LORD, who is like You, Who delivers the poor from one stronger than he, and the poor and needy from one who would rob him?" For with You is the fountain of life; in Your light we see light.[C] How precious is Your lovingkindness, O God! The chil- 975R
dren of men take refuge in the shadow of Your wings.

[A] Or: "For in Him our heart shall rejoice, for in His holy name we have placed our trust" — This alternative uses future tense for 'rejoice' and expands 'trusted' to 'placed our trust,' which might better express the ongoing nature of the faithful relationship being described. This could be preferable in contexts emphasizing the continuing nature of divine care.

[B] Or: "The LORD is the redeemer of His servants' souls, and all who seek shelter in Him will not be held guilty" — This alternative emphasizes God's identity as redeemer and uses the more concrete 'seek shelter' for the Hebrew 'חסים'. It also renders 'יֶאְשְׁמוּ' as 'held guilty' rather than 'condemned,' which might better capture the legal connotation of the Hebrew term.

[C] Or: "For with You is the source of life; by Your light we perceive light" — This translation uses 'source' for מְקוֹר instead of 'fountain' and 'perceive' for נִרְאֶה instead of 'see,' which might better capture the spiritual and intellectual dimensions of divine illumination being described. In kabbalistic contexts like Ma'avar Yabok, this verse often refers to spiritual perception beyond physical sight.

[1] The Hebrew text concludes with God's direct promise of healing (וּרְפָאתִיו), functioning as both the climax and summary of this collection of prophetic verses. This divine first-person commitment to heal serves as a powerful conclusion to this section of healing prayers in Ma'avar Yabok.

[2] I've translated the Hebrew נַפְשֵׁנוּ (nafshenu) as "our soul" in the singular following the Hebrew original, though in English "our souls" might sound more natural. This singular form emphasizes the collective nature of the prayer, with the community speaking as one entity.

[3] This striking physical imagery represents the totality of one's being praising God. In the context of healing prayers, this suggests that even the physical body (represented by bones) participates in acknowledging divine salvation.

Yabok, these verses connect physical healing with moral and spiritual renewal, suggesting that true healing addresses both body and soul through ethical living and divine connection. | Cf. Isaiah 55:13 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse functions as a metaphor for the transformation of suffering into blessing, suggesting that illness and approaching death will ultimately yield to a more beautiful and enduring spiritual state. | Cf. Isaiah 57:19 — This final verse emphasizes divine healing as both physical and spiritual, bringing peace to both those distant from and close to God. In Ma'avar Yabok, it suggests that prayer itself ('fruit of the lips') can create healing and peace. | Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok's inclusion of these particular prophetic verses reflects the kabbalistic approach of the Zohar, which reinterprets national redemption narratives as templates for individual spiritual journeys, particularly at the end of life.

גּוֹל עַל יְהוָה דַּרְכֶּךָ וּבְטַח עָלָיו
וְהוּא יַעֲשֶׂה: וְהוֹצִיא כָאוֹר צִדְקֶךָ
וּמִשְׁפָּטְךָ כַּצָּהֳרָיִם: דֹּם לַיהוָה וְהִתְחוֹלֵל לוֹ
וְאַל תִּתְחַר בְּמַצְלִיחַ דַּרְכּוֹ בְּאִישׁ עֹשֶׂה מְזִמּוֹת:
חֲדַל מֵאַף וְעֲזֹב חֵמָה אַל תִּתְחַר אַךְ לְהָרֵעַ:
כִּי מְרֵעִים יִכָּרֵתוּן וְקוֵי יְהוָה הֵמָּה יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ:
וְעוֹד מְעַט וְאֵין רָשָׁע וְהִתְבּוֹנַנְתָּ עַל מְקוֹמוֹ וְאֵינֶנּוּ:
וְעֲנָוִים יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ וְהִתְעַנְּגוּ עַל רֹב שָׁלוֹם:
זוֹמֵם רָשָׁע לַצַּדִּיק וְחָרֹק עָלָיו שִׁנָּיו:
אֲדֹנָי יִשְׂחַק לוֹ כִּי רָאָה כִּי יָבוֹא יוֹמוֹ:
חֶרֶב פָּתְחוּ רְשָׁעִים וְדָרְכוּ קַשְׁתָּם לְהַפִּיל עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן
לִטְבֹּחַ יִשְׁרֵי דָרֶךְ: חַרְבָּם תָּבוֹא בְלִבָּם וְקַשְׁתוֹתָם תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה:
טוֹב מְעַט לַצַּדִּיק מֵהֲמוֹן רְשָׁעִים רַבִּים:
כִּי זְרוֹעוֹת רְשָׁעִים תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה וְסֹמֵךְ צַדִּיקִים יְהוָה:
יוֹדֵעַ יְהוָה יְמֵי תְמִימִם וְנַחֲלָתָם לְעוֹלָם תִּהְיֶה:
לֹא יֵבֹשׁוּ בְּעֵת רָעָה וּבִימֵי רְעָבוֹן יִשְׂבָּעוּ:
כִּי רְשָׁעִים יֹאבֵדוּ וְאוֹיְבֵי יְהוָה כִּיקַר כָּרִים כָּלוּ בֶּעָשָׁן כָּלּוּ:
לוֶה רָשָׁע וְלֹא יְשַׁלֵּם וְצַדִּיק חוֹנֵן וְנוֹתֵן:
כִּי מְבֹרָכָיו יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ וּמְקֻלָּלָיו יִכָּרֵתוּ:
מֵיְהוָה מִצְעֲדֵי גֶבֶר כּוֹנָנוּ וְדַרְכּוֹ יֶחְפָּץ:
כִּי יִפֹּל לֹא יוּטָל כִּי יְהוָה סוֹמֵךְ יָדוֹ:
נַעַר הָיִיתִי גַּם זָקַנְתִּי וְלֹא רָאִיתִי צַדִּיק נֶעֱזָב וְזַרְעוֹ מְבַקֶּשׁ לָחֶם:
כָּל הַיּוֹם חוֹנֵן וּמַלְוֶה וְזַרְעוֹ לִבְרָכָה:
סוּר מֵרָע וַעֲשֵׂה טוֹב וּשְׁכֹן לָעַד:
כִּי יְהוָה אֹהֵב מִשְׁפָּט וְלֹא יַעֲזֹב אֶת חֲסִידָיו לְעוֹלָם נִשְׁמָרוּ וְזֶרַע רְשָׁעִים נִכְרָת:
צַדִּיקִים יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ וְיִשְׁכְּנוּ לָעַד עָלֶיהָ:
פִּי צַדִּיק יֶהְגֶּה חָכְמָה וּלְשׁוֹנוֹ תְּדַבֵּר מִשְׁפָּט:
תּוֹרַת אֱלֹהָיו בְּלִבּוֹ לֹא תִמְעַד אֲשֻׁרָיו:
צוֹפֶה רָשָׁע לַצַּדִּיק וּמְבַקֵּשׁ לַהֲמִיתוֹ:
יְהוָה לֹא יַעַזְבֶנּוּ בְיָדוֹ וְלֹא יַרְשִׁיעֶנּוּ בְּהִשָּׁפְטוֹ:
קַוֵּה אֶל יְהוָה וְשָׁמֹר דַּרְכּוֹ וְיָרוֹמִמְךָ לָרֶשֶׁת אָרֶץ בְּהִכָּרֵת רְשָׁעִים תִּרְאֶה:
רָאִיתִי רָשָׁע עָרִיץ וּמִתְיַלֵּל כְּאֶזְרָח רַעֲנָן:
וַיַּעֲבֹר וְהִנֵּה אֵינֶנּוּ וָאֲבַקְשֵׁהוּ וְלֹא נִמְצָא:
שְׁמֹר תָּם וּרְאֵה יָשָׁר כִּי אַחֲרִית לְאִישׁ שָׁלוֹם:
וּפֹשְׁעִים נִשְׁמְדוּ יַחְדָּו אַחֲרִית רְשָׁעִים נִכְרָתָה:
תְּשׁוּעַת צַדִּיקִים מֵיְהוָה מָעוּזָּם בְּעֵת צָרָה:
וַיַּעְזְרֵם יְהוָה וַיְפַלְּטֵם יְפַלְּטֵם מֵרְשָׁעִים וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם
כִּי חָסוּ בוֹ: וְעַתָּה מַה־קִּוִּיתִי אֲדֹנָי תּוֹחַלְתִּי לְךָ הִיא: שִׁמְעָה תְפִלָּתִי
יְהוָה וְשַׁוְעָתִי הַאֲזִינָה אֶל דִּמְעָתִי אַל תֶּחֱרַשׁ כִּי גֵר אָנֹכִי עִמָּךְ תּוֹשָׁב
כְּכָל אֲבוֹתָי: יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה: [i]

Delight yourself in the LORD, and He will give you the desires of your heart. Commit your way to the LORD; trust also in Him, and He will do it.[A] He will bring forth your righteousness as the light, and your justice as the noonday. Wait for the LORD and keep His way, and He will exalt you to inherit the land; when the wicked are cut off, you will see it. Let not the foot of pride come upon me, nor the hand of the wicked drive me away. But the salvation of the righteous is from the LORD; He is their stronghold in time of trouble. The LORD helps them and delivers them; He delivers them from the wicked and saves them, because they take refuge in Him. And now, Lord, what do I wait for? My hope is in You.[1] Hear my prayer, O LORD, and give ear to my cry; do not be silent at my tears; for I am a stronger with You, a sojourner, as all my fathers were. The LORD of hosts is with us;[2] the God of Jacob is our refuge. Selah.

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יאמר למען יחלצון ידידיך[ii] וגומר

He shall recite: "That Your beloved ones may be

[A] Or: "Roll your path onto the LORD; trust in Him, and He will act" — This alternative preserves the physical metaphor in the Hebrew 'גּוֹל' (roll) and uses 'act' for 'יַעֲשֶׂה' rather than 'do it,' which might better capture the sense of divine intervention. The physical imagery of 'rolling' one's burden onto God would be especially meaningful in a healing context.

[1] The Hebrew תּוֹחַלְתִּי literally means "my expectation" or "what I wait for," conveying both hope and patient anticipation. In the context of illness, this represents placing all one's expectation for healing or peaceful transition in God's hands.

[2] The divine title יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת (LORD of hosts) evokes God's command over angelic armies, emphasizing divine power and protection. This concluding verse offers powerful reassurance that divine protection surrounds those who are ill or dying.

[i] Cf. Psalm 33:20-22 — These verses express collective trust in God as protector, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context would reassure the sick person that they remain under divine care despite their suffering. | Cf. Psalm 35:10 — The image of 'all my bones' praising God would resonate deeply in a healing context, suggesting that even the physical body participates in acknowledging divine deliverance. | Cf. Psalm 36:8-10 — The images of taking refuge 'under God's wings' and experiencing 'the fountain of life' would provide profound comfort to the ill, promising divine nurture and protection even at the threshold of death. | Cf. Psalm 37:3-7 — These verses encourage the sick to maintain their trust in God and commit their path to Him, promising that their righteousness will ultimately be recognized 'as the noonday' despite current suffering. | Cf. Psalm 39:13 — The description of human life as a temporary sojourn aligns perfectly with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on death as a transition, reminding readers that all humans are merely passing through this world. | Cf. Psalm 46:8 — This concluding verse offers powerful reassurance of divine presence and protection, making it an ideal closing for a healing prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Seder Dalet — This passage appears to be the Writings (Ketuvim) section of verses in the fourth prayer sequence, following psalms and preceding the standard concluding healing formulas. | Cf. Zohar — The references to divine light ('in Your light we see light') connect to kabbalistic teachings about divine illumination as a source of healing and spiritual transformation, themes central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach.

[ii] This is the beginning of a verse from Psalm 60:7/108:7, which continues "הושיעה ימינך וענני" ("save with Your right hand and answer me"). The "וגומר" (etc.) indicates that the prayer leader should continue with the rest of this verse.

915 רפאני ה׳[i] וגומר ככל הסדר הכתוב למעלה צורי וגואלי׳[ii iii] delivered, etc." "Heal me, O LORD, etc." following the complete order written above until "my Rock and my Redeemer."[A]

סדר ה[iv v] Order Five[1] 1000R

יתחיל אנא ה׳ הושיעה נא וגו׳[vi] ככתוב למעלה בסדר א׳[vii] ואחר כך יאמר מזמור מ״ב 920 He shall begin "Please, O LORD, save us," etc., as written above in the First Order,[2] and afterwards he shall recite Psalm 42 or 43 or 51 or 61,[3] and after

[A] Or: "One should recite: "That Your beloved ones may be delivered..." "Heal me, O LORD..." following the entire sequence written above through "my Rock and my Redeemer."" — This alternate translation uses "one should" instead of "he shall" for a more gender-neutral instruction, and replaces "etc." with ellipses to indicate continuation. It might be preferable in contexts seeking more inclusive language while maintaining the liturgical instructions' meaning.

[1] This simple heading marks the beginning of the fifth liturgical sequence in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer system. Though brief, it serves as an important navigational marker in the text, helping those caring for the sick or dying to find the appropriate prayers and readings for their situation. These carefully organized prayer sequences were designed to provide spiritual comfort and healing for both the ill person and those attending them.

[2] This is a navigational instruction in the prayer manual, directing the reader to recite the opening formula that was provided in full earlier in the text. The phrase 'Ana Hashem hoshiah na' (Please, O LORD, save us) comes from Psalm 118:25 and was a common opening for liturgical prayers.

[3] These four psalms share themes relevant to illness and spiritual distress. Psalm 42-43 (sometimes

[i] This begins a verse from Jeremiah 17:14, which continues "וארפא הושיעני ואושעה כי תהלתי אתה" ("and I will be healed; save me, and I will be saved, for You are my praise"). This prayer appears earlier in the text as part of a standard formula to be recited three times.

[ii] The final phrase "צורי וגואלי" (my Rock and my Redeemer) comes from Psalm 19:15 and marks the conclusion of this prayer sequence. The apostrophe after this word in the Hebrew indicates an abbreviation.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 60:7 — This verse is used as an opening formula in the standardized prayer sequence, invoking divine deliverance for those whom God loves. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this takes on added significance as a plea for the sick person's deliverance from illness or a peaceful transition at death. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This verse has been adapted as a healing formula in Ma'avar Yabok, to be recited three times as part of the standard closing for each liturgical sequence. Its use reflects the text's emphasis on divine healing and salvation, presenting God as the ultimate source of both physical and spiritual restoration. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — This phrase serves as a standard conclusion to the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, creating a formal closing that invokes God as both stable foundation ('Rock') and active savior ('Redeemer'). Its use connects these healing prayers to the broader Jewish liturgical tradition where this verse is frequently used to conclude prayers.

[iv] This heading identifies the fifth of eight liturgical sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer system for healing the sick and comforting the dying. Each 'seder' follows a similar pattern with specific prayers and readings.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's Seder section — The eight prayer sequences follow a consistent structure with opening prayers, psalms, biblical verses organized by source, and concluding prayers. Each begins with the same opening formula but offers different psalm options appropriate to various situations related to illness and approaching death. | Cf. The title 'Ma'avar Yabok' — These prayer sequences are designed to assist in this spiritual crossing by providing structured liturgical support for those who are ill or approaching death.

[vi] This instruction indicates that the prayer leader should begin with the opening formula that starts with 'Ana Hashem hoshiah na' (Please, O LORD, save us). The abbreviation 'וגו' (etc.) indicates that the complete formula, which was presented earlier in the text, should be recited without being repeated in full here.

[vii] This refers to the First Order (Seder Alef) presented earlier in Ma'avar Yabok, where the complete opening prayer formula was written out in full. This cross-reference helps users navigate between different sections of the prayer manual.

או מ״ג או נ״א או ס״א[i] ואח״כ יאמר ברוך תהיה וגו׳:[ii iii]

that he shall say “Blessed shall you be,” etc.[1]

(תהלים מב) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מַשְׂכִּיל לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח: כְּאַיָּל תַּעֲרֹג[iv] עַל־אֲפִיקֵי־מָיִם[v] כֵּן נַפְשִׁי תַעֲרֹג אֵלֶיךָ אֱלֹהִים: צָמְאָה נַפְשִׁי לֵאלֹהִים לְאֵל חָי מָתַי אָבוֹא וְאֵרָאֶה פְּנֵי אֱלֹהִים: הָיְתָה־לִּי דִמְעָתִי לֶחֶם יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה בֶּאֱמֹר אֵלַי כָּל־הַיּוֹם אַיֵּה אֱלֹהֶיךָ: אֵלֶּה אֶזְכְּרָה וְאֶשְׁפְּכָה עָלַי נַפְשִׁי כִּי אֶעֱבֹר בַּסָּךְ[vi] אֶדַּדֵּם עַד־בֵּית אֱלֹהִים בְּקוֹל־רִנָּה וְתוֹדָה הָמוֹן חוֹגֵג: מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי וַתֶּהֱמִי

(Psalm 42) For the conductor, a maskil by the sons of Korah. As a deer longs for flowing streams,[2] so my soul longs for You, O God. My soul thirsts for God, for the living God; when shall I come and appear before God?[3] My tears have been my food day and night,[4] as they say to me all day long, “Where is your God?” These things I remember and pour out my soul within me: how I used to go with the multitude, leading them in procession to the house of God, with the voice of joy and thanksgiving, a celebrating throng. Why are you downcast, O my soul, and why are you disquieted within me?[A] Hope in God, for I

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[A] Or: “Why do you bow down, my soul, and why do you moan within me?” — This more

considered a single composition) expresses deep longing for God during distress; Psalm 51 is a profound prayer of repentance; and Psalm 61 is a plea for divine protection in times of overwhelming circumstances. The choice among these options allows the prayer leader to select the psalm most appropriate to the sick person’s specific condition.

[1] This refers to a prayer beginning with ‘Barukh tihyeh’ (Blessed shall you be) that appears later in the text. This prayer, which begins with Deuteronomy 7:14, contains promises of divine blessing, protection from illness, and healing.

[2] This powerful opening image establishes the psalm’s central metaphor of spiritual thirst. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this would resonate deeply with the sick or dying person who feels distant from normal religious life and community.

[3] In the original context, this likely referred to pilgrimage to the Temple. In Ma’avar Yabok, this question takes on additional significance for the ill person contemplating their mortality and future divine encounter, either through recovery and return to synagogue worship or through death and spiritual transition.

[4] This powerful metaphor of consuming one’s own grief would be particularly relevant to the sick person who might be unable to eat properly and instead subsists on their suffering.

[i] The Hebrew abbreviations מ״ב, מ״ג, נ״א, and ס״א refer to Psalms 42, 43, 51, and 61 respectively. These psalms were carefully selected for their thematic relevance to illness and approaching death. The prayer leader is given a choice among these options, allowing flexibility to select the most appropriate psalm for the specific situation.

[ii] The phrase ‘ברוך תהיה וגו” (Blessed shall you be, etc.) refers to a prayer beginning with those words that appears later in the text. The abbreviation ‘וגו” indicates that the full prayer should be recited although it is not repeated here in the instructions.

[iii] Cf. Deuteronomy 7:14-15 — This biblical passage, which begins the prayer mentioned in the instruction, would have provided both comfort and theological framing for illness as potentially related to divine judgment but also promising divine healing and blessing to the faithful. | Cf. Psalm 51 — This psalm’s inclusion as an option for the sick reflects Ma’avar Yabok’s theological framework that illness could be connected to sin, and proper repentance might contribute to healing. Its themes of purification (‘Cleanse me with hyssop’) would be especially resonant in the context of illness.

[iv] This superscription indicates the psalm was composed for or by the sons of Korah, a Levitical family of Temple musicians. “Maskil” likely indicates a didactic or contemplative psalm requiring special attention.

[v] The Hebrew uses feminine “תַּעֲרֹג” (longs) with the masculine noun “אַיָּל” (deer), possibly implying a female deer or hind, creating a poignant image of desperate thirst and longing.

[vi] The phrase “בַּסָּךְ” is difficult to translate precisely. It may refer to a thicket, a throng, or a procession, but in context likely refers to leading the festive procession to the Temple.

עָלַי הוֹחִיל לֵאלֹהִים כִּי־עוֹד
אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנָיו: אֱלֹהַי עָלַי
נַפְשִׁי תִשְׁתּוֹחָח עַל־כֵּן אֶזְכָּרְךָ
מֵאֶרֶץ יַרְדֵּן וְחֶרְמוֹנִים מֵהַר
מִצְעָר: תְּהוֹם־אֶל־תְּהוֹם קוֹרֵא
לְקוֹל צִנּוֹרֶיךָ[i] כָּל־מִשְׁבָּרֶיךָ
וְגַלֶּיךָ עָלַי עָבָרוּ: יוֹמָם יְצַוֶּה יְיָ
חַסְדּוֹ וּבַלַּיְלָה שִׁירָה עִמִּי תְּפִלָּה
לְאֵל חַיָּי: אוֹמְרָה לְאֵל סַלְעִי לָמָּה
שְׁכַחְתָּנִי לָמָּה־קֹדֵר אֵלֵךְ בְּלַחַץ
אוֹיֵב: בְּרֶצַח בְּעַצְמוֹתַי[ii] חֵרְפוּנִי
צוֹרְרָי בְּאָמְרָם אֵלַי כָּל־הַיּוֹם
אַיֵּה אֱלֹהֶיךָ: מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי
נַפְשִׁי וּמַה־תֶּהֱמִי עָלָי הוֹחִילִי
לֵאלֹהִים כִּי־עוֹד אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעֹת
פָּנַי וֵאלֹהָי: [iii]

shall yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence. My God, my soul is downcast within me; therefore I remember You from the land of the Jordan and the peaks of Hermon, from Mount Mizar.[A] Deep calls to deep at the sound of Your waterfalls; all Your breakers and waves have swept over me.[1] By day the LORD commands His steadfast love, and at night His song is with me, a prayer to the God of my life. I say to God, my Rock, "Why have You forgotten me? Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?" As with a shattering of my bones, my adversaries taunt me, saying to me all day long, "Where is your God?" Why are you downcast, O my soul, and why are you disquieted within me? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him, the salvation of my countenance and my God.

(תהלים מג) שָׁפְטֵנִי אֱלֹהִים וְרִיבָה
רִיבִי מִגּוֹי לֹא־חָסִיד[iv] מֵאִישׁ
מִרְמָה וְעַוְלָה תְּפַלְּטֵנִי: כִּי־אַתָּה
אֱלֹהֵי מָעוּזִּי לָמָּה זְנַחְתָּנִי
לָמָּה־קֹדֵר אֶתְהַלֵּךְ בְּלַחַץ

(Psalm 43) Judge me, O God, and plead my case against an ungodly nation; deliver me from the deceitful and unjust man. For You are the God of my strength; why have You cast me off? Why do I go mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?

literal translation of the Hebrew verbs preserves the physical imagery of bowing down (שָׁחָה) and moaning/groaning (הָמָה), which connects to bodily experience of the sick person in Ma'avar Yabok's context.

[A] Or: "from the land of the Jordan and the Hermons, from the humble mountain" — The word מִצְעָר can be understood as a proper name (Mount Mizar) or as 'small/humble mountain.' This alternate reading creates a meaningful contrast between the majestic Hermons and the small mountain, potentially symbolizing the human soul's humility before God.

[1] The imagery of overwhelming divine waters represents both the psalmist's sufferings and God's overwhelming presence. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this captures the experience of serious illness as both a spiritual trial and an encounter with divine power.

[i] This powerful poetic image of "deep calling to deep" depicts overwhelming waves of suffering, using the same word "תְּהוֹם" (deep) that appears in Genesis 1:2 to describe primordial waters, suggesting chaos returning.

[ii] The phrase literally means "with murder/crushing in my bones" and communicates how the taunts of enemies physically affect the psalmist, creating bone-deep pain.

[iii] Cf. Psalms 42-43 — This psalm would have been recognized as part of a longer prayer expressing spiritual thirst during times of separation from the Temple worship. In Ma'avar Yabok, it functions as a profound expression of the soul's yearning for divine connection, especially relevant for the sick who feel distant from God. | Cf. Zohar — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences would evoke kabbalistic interpretations where the soul's longing for God represents the mystical desire for union with the Divine Presence, particularly relevant during illness when one feels spiritually distant. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 3a — The imagery of 'deep calls to deep' and divine waves passing over the psalmist connects to the rabbinic concept of God's own mourning for separation from Israel, creating a parallel between human and divine suffering that would resonate with the sick person's experience of separation from normal religious life.

[iv] The term 'ungodly nation' (literally 'a nation without loving-kindness') is often interpreted in Jewish tradition as referring to internal spiritual enemies as well as external ones. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this could represent the negative spiritual forces believed to attack the sick or dying person.

אוֹר־אֲמִתְּךָ הֲמָּה
יַנְחוּנִי יְבִיאוּנִי אֶל־הַר־קָדְשֶׁךָ
וְאֶל־מִשְׁכְּנוֹתֶיךָ: וְאָבוֹאָה
אֶל־מִזְבַּח אֱלֹהִים[i] אֶל־אֵל שִׂמְחַת
960 גִּילִי וְאוֹדְךָ בְכִנּוֹר אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהָי:
מַה־תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי[ii] וּמַה־תֶּהֱמִי
עָלָי הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים כִּי־עוֹד
אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעֹת פָּנַי וֵאלֹהָי: [iii]

Send forth Your light and Your truth; let them lead me, let them bring me to Your holy mountain and to Your dwelling places. Then I will go to the altar of God, to God, the joy of my delight,[1] and I will praise You with the harp, O God, my God. Why are you downcast, O my soul? And why do you moan within me? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him, the deliverances of my countenance[2] and my God.

(תהלים נא) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר
965 לְדָוִד: בְּבוֹא־אֵלָיו נָתָן הַנָּבִיא
כַּאֲשֶׁר־בָּא אֶל־בַּת־שָׁבַע[iv]: חָנֵּנִי
אֱלֹהִים כְּחַסְדֶּךָ כְּרֹב רַחֲמֶיךָ מְחֵה
פְשָׁעָי: (הרבה) [הֶרֶב][v] כַּבְּסֵנִי
מֵעֲוֹנִי וּמֵחַטָּאתִי טַהֲרֵנִי: כִּי־פְשָׁעַי
970 אֲנִי אֵדָע וְחַטָּאתִי נֶגְדִּי תָמִיד: לְךָ
לְבַדְּךָ חָטָאתִי[vi] וְהָרַע בְּעֵינֶיךָ
עָשִׂיתִי לְמַעַן תִּצְדַּק בְּדָבְרֶךָ

For the choir director. A psalm of David, when Nathan the prophet came to him after he had gone in to Bathsheba. Have mercy on me, O God, according to Your lovingkindness; according to the abundance of Your compassion, blot out my transgressions. Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity and cleanse me from my sin. For I know my transgressions, and my sin is always before me. Against You, You alone, have I sinned and done what is evil in

[1]The Hebrew phrase 'שִׂמְחַת גִּילִי' combines two terms for joy, creating an emphatic expression that suggests profound, ecstatic joy. I've chosen to translate this as 'the joy of my delight' to capture this intensification.

[2]The phrase 'יְשׁוּעֹת פָּנַי' (literally 'salvations of my face') is difficult to render in English. It suggests that divine deliverance is reflected in the psalmist's face or appearance, transforming sorrow into visible joy. This connects to the Jewish concept that physical illness and spiritual distress are interconnected, with healing manifesting both spiritually and physically.

[i]The 'altar of God' represents the ultimate destination in this psalm's spiritual journey. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would be understood as the soul's arrival at divine presence after traversing the difficulties of illness or the transition of death.

[ii]This refrain, which also appears in Psalm 42, has the speaker addressing his own soul, creating a form of spiritual self-dialogue. This technique was highly valued in Jewish spiritual practice, especially for the ill and dying who were encouraged to engage in this kind of internal conversation to maintain hope.

[iii]Cf. Psalm 42 — Psalm 43 was likely originally part of the same composition as Psalm 42, as evidenced by the identical refrain. In Ma'avar Yabok, these psalms were chosen for the sick and dying because they express both spiritual distress and hope for divine deliverance, mirroring the experience of someone facing serious illness. | Cf. Zohar — The phrase 'Send forth Your light and Your truth' resonates with kabbalistic concepts found throughout Ma'avar Yabok, where divine light (אור) represents spiritual illumination and healing power. This would be understood as a request for divine emanations to guide the soul through darkness, whether of illness or approaching death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The psalm's journey motif—from oppression to divine altar—mirrors the book's central metaphor of 'crossing the Yabok,' representing the soul's transition from distress to divine presence. The phrase 'holy mountain' also resonates with the book's use of ascent imagery for spiritual elevation.

[iv]This superscription places the psalm in the historical context of King David's repentance after committing adultery with Bathsheba and arranging the death of her husband Uriah (2 Samuel 11-12). The psalm thus became the paradigmatic model for confession and repentance in Jewish tradition.

[v]The text shows an editorial correction in the Hebrew. The original text read 'harbeh' (increase), while the corrected reading in brackets is 'herev' (multiply/thoroughly), a more grammatically appropriate form in this context.

[vi]This phrase has been interpreted in various ways, since David clearly sinned against Uriah and Bathsheba as well. Jewish commentators often explain this as acknowledging that all sin ultimately violates divine law, or that only God can forgive the spiritual dimension of sin, even when humans are also wronged.

תִּזְכֶּה בְשָׁפְטֶךָ: הֵן־בְּעָוֹן חוֹלָלְתִּי
וּבְחֵטְא יֶחֱמַתְנִי אִמִּי: הֵן־אֱמֶת
חָפַצְתָּ בַּטֻּחוֹת וּבְסָתֻם חָכְמָה
תוֹדִיעֵנִי: תְּחַטְּאֵנִי בְאֵזוֹב[i] וְאֶטְהָר
תְּכַבְּסֵנִי וּמִשֶּׁלֶג אַלְבִּין: תַּשְׁמִיעֵנִי
שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה תָּגֵלְנָה עֲצָמוֹת
דִּכִּיתָ: הַסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מֵחַטָּאָי
וְכָל־עֲוֹנֹתַי מְחֵה: לֵב טָהוֹר
בְּרָא־לִי אֱלֹהִים וְרוּחַ נָכוֹן חַדֵּשׁ
בְּקִרְבִּי: אַל־תַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי מִלְּפָנֶיךָ
וְרוּחַ קָדְשְׁךָ אַל־תִּקַּח מִמֶּנִּי:
הָשִׁיבָה לִּי שְׂשׂוֹן יִשְׁעֶךָ וְרוּחַ
נְדִיבָה תִסְמְכֵנִי: אֲלַמְּדָה פּוֹשְׁעִים
דְּרָכֶיךָ וְחַטָּאִים אֵלֶיךָ יָשׁוּבוּ:
הַצִּילֵנִי מִדָּמִים[ii] אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהֵי
תְשׁוּעָתִי תְּרַנֵּן לְשׁוֹנִי צִדְקָתֶךָ:
אֲדֹנָי שְׂפָתַי תִּפְתָּח וּפִי יַגִּיד
תְּהִלָּתֶךָ: כִּי לֹא־תַחְפֹּץ זֶבַח
וְאֶתְּנָה עוֹלָה לֹא תִרְצֶה: זִבְחֵי
אֱלֹהִים רוּחַ נִשְׁבָּרָה[iii] לֵב־נִשְׁבָּר
וְנִדְכֶּה אֱלֹהִים לֹא תִבְזֶה: הֵיטִיבָה
בִרְצוֹנְךָ אֶת־צִיּוֹן תִּבְנֶה חוֹמוֹת
יְרוּשָׁלָם: אָז תַּחְפֹּץ זִבְחֵי־צֶדֶק
עוֹלָה וְכָלִיל אָז יַעֲלוּ עַל־מִזְבַּחֲךָ

Your sight, so that You may be justified when You speak and blameless when You judge. Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin my mother conceived me. Behold, You desire truth in the inward parts, and in the hidden part You will make me know wisdom. Purify me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow.[1] Let me hear joy and gladness, that the bones You have crushed may rejoice.[2] Hide Your face from my sins and blot out all my iniquities. Create in me a clean heart,[3] O God, and renew a steadfast spirit within me. Do not cast me away from Your presence,[4] and do not take Your Holy Spirit from me. Restore to me the joy of Your salvation, and uphold me with a willing spirit. Then I will teach transgressors Your ways,[5] and sinners will return to You. Deliver me from bloodguilt, O God, God of my salvation, and my tongue will sing aloud of Your righteousness. O Lord, open my lips, and my mouth will declare Your praise. For You do not delight in sacrifice, or I would give it; You do not take pleasure in burnt offerings. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, You will not despise. Do good to Zion in Your good pleasure;[6] build the walls

[1]The imagery of being cleansed 'whiter than snow' is a powerful metaphor for complete spiritual purification. In Jewish mystical tradition, this whitening represents the transformation of spiritual qualities, similar to how Ma'avar Yabok describes the evil inclination being 'whitened like snow' in the afterlife.

[2]This vivid physical imagery of crushed bones parallels Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of physical suffering as potentially beneficial to the soul, breaking down negative spiritual forces while strengthening the soul's dominance.

[3]The Hebrew verb 'bera' (create) is the same used in Genesis 1:1, suggesting that spiritual renewal requires divine creative power comparable to the creation of the world. This reinforces Ma'avar Yabok's theme that genuine spiritual transformation requires divine intervention.

[4]This plea reflects the fear of spiritual abandonment, which in Ma'avar Yabok's framework would be understood as particularly relevant for the dying, who seek assurance that their souls will be received by God rather than rejected.

[5]This verse establishes the principle that one who has experienced forgiveness is obligated to guide others toward repentance, similar to how Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that properly guiding others to repentance creates merit that strengthens divine forces.

[6]The psalm's conclusion shifts from individual to communal concerns, suggesting that personal repentance contributes to collective redemption. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's integration of individual spiritual preparation with broader cosmic repair.

[i]This references the purification ritual described in Leviticus 14:4-7, where hyssop was dipped in the blood of a sacrificed bird and used to sprinkle a person being cleansed from ritual impurity. The metaphor connects physical purification rituals with spiritual cleansing.

[ii]The Hebrew 'damim' (literally 'bloods') refers to bloodguilt or blood-shed, likely referring to David's responsibility for Uriah's death. This is one of the most explicit references to the specific sin that prompted the psalm.

[iii]This key verse establishes the spiritual principle that internal contrition is more valuable than external ritual, a theme that runs throughout prophetic literature. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this principle is particularly relevant to confession on the deathbed.

פָּרִים׃[i]

of Jerusalem. Then You will delight in righteous sacrifices, burnt offering and whole burnt offering; then bulls will be offered on Your altar.

(תהלים סא) לַמְנַצֵּחַ עַל־נְגִינַת
לְדָוִד׃[ii] שִׁמְעָה אֱלֹהִים רִנָּתִי
הַקְשִׁיבָה תְּפִלָּתִי׃ מִקְצֵה
הָאָרֶץ אֵלֶיךָ אֶקְרָא בַּעֲטֹף
לִבִּי[iii] בְּצוּר־יָרוּם מִמֶּנִּי תַנְחֵנִי׃[iv]
כִּי־הָיִיתָ מַחְסֶה לִי מִגְדַּל־עֹז
מִפְּנֵי אוֹיֵב׃ אָגוּרָה בְאָהֳלְךָ
עוֹלָמִים אֶחֱסֶה בְסֵתֶר כְּנָפֶיךָ
סֶּלָה[v]׃ כִּי־אַתָּה אֱלֹהִים שָׁמַעְתָּ

(Psalm 61) For the chief musician, on a stringed instrument.[1] Of David. Hear my cry, O God; attend to my prayer. From the end of the earth I call to You when my heart is faint;[2] lead me to the rock that is higher than I. For You have been a shelter for me, a strong tower against the enemy. I will dwell in Your tent forever;[A] I will take refuge in the shelter of Your wings.[3] Selah. For You, O God, have heard my vows; You have given me the heritage of those who

[A] Or: "I will sojourn in Your tent for all eternity" — The verb אָגוּרָה carries a connotation of 'sojourning' or 'dwelling as a guest,' which better captures the temporary nature of earthly life compared to eternal dwelling. This nuance is significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context where the transition from temporary earthly dwelling to eternal spiritual existence is a central theme.

[1] This psalm appears in Ma'avar Yabok's fifth prayer sequence specifically selected for the sick. Its themes of divine protection during weakness and finding refuge in God make it particularly appropriate for those experiencing serious illness.

[2] The Hebrew בַּעֲטֹף לִבִּי literally means "when my heart is covered/wrapped/faint" and conveys a sense of overwhelming weakness or despair. For the ill person reciting this psalm, this phrase would acknowledge their physical and spiritual exhaustion while still maintaining hope in divine assistance.

[3] This metaphor of divine protection under God's wings appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. In kabbalistic interpretation, it represents the soul finding protection under the wings of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), a concept particularly relevant for the vulnerable soul during illness or approaching death.

[i] Cf. 2 Samuel 12:1-14 — The psalm's heading explicitly connects it to David's repentance after his grave sins involving Bathsheba. This connection would remind readers of the severity of sin that can be forgiven through proper confession. | Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok frequently draws on Zoharic interpretations of confession (vidui) as having profound metaphysical effects. This psalm, as the quintessential confession prayer, would be understood in the context of the book as creating actual spiritual transformations. | Cf. Leviticus 14:4-7 — The psalm's reference to hyssop would remind readers of the ritual purification procedures for those with tzara'at (often translated as leprosy), connecting spiritual impurity with physical impurity, and suggesting that sin requires similar purification rituals. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 34b — This psalm, as the paradigmatic penitential prayer, connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on the spiritual power of genuine repentance that can transform one's spiritual fate, even on the deathbed.

[ii] This superscription indicates the psalm was intended to be performed with stringed instrumental accompaniment. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm appears in the fifth liturgical order (Seder Hei) as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick.

[iii] The phrase "when my heart is faint" (בַּעֲטֹף לִבִּי) resonates strongly in the context of illness, as it expresses the weakness and distress experienced by the sick person. The psalmist's sense of being at "the end of the earth" similarly captures the feeling of isolation that often accompanies serious illness.

[iv] The "rock that is higher than I" represents divine strength and stability when human strength fails, a particularly relevant metaphor for the sick person seeking divine support beyond their own diminished capabilities.

[v] The image of taking refuge "in the shelter of Your wings" (בְּסֵתֶר כְּנָפֶיךָ) appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok as a metaphor for divine protection, particularly for the soul of the sick or dying person. In kabbalistic terms, this represents being brought under the protection of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah).

לְנָדָרַי נָתַתָּ יִרְאֵי שְׁמֶךָ[i]: יָמִים עַל־יְמֵי־מֶלֶךְ תּוֹסִיף שָׁנוֹתָיו כְּמוֹ־דֹר וָדֹר[ii]: יֵשֵׁב עוֹלָם לִפְנֵי 1010 אֱלֹהִים חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת מַן יְנִצְּרֵהוּ[iii]: כֵּן אֲזַמְּרָה שִׁמְךָ לָעַד לְשַׁלְּמִי נְדָרַי יוֹם יוֹם[iv]: [v]

fear Your name.[1] You will add days to the king's days; his years will be like many generations.[2] He shall abide before God forever;[A] appoint mercy and truth to preserve him.[B] So I will sing praise to Your name forever, that I may fulfill my vows day by day.[3] 1095R

(תורה) בָּרוּךְ תִּהְיֶה מִכָּל (Torah) You shall be blessed above all peoples;[C] there

[A] Or: "May he sit enthroned before God eternally" — The verb יֵשֵׁב can have royal connotations of 'sitting enthroned,' which could emphasize the dignified status of the righteous soul in God's presence after death—a theme consistent with Ma'avar Yabok's portrayal of the afterlife for those who have properly prepared themselves spiritually.

[B] Or: "they shall guard him" — The unusual form מַן could be interpreted as a plural subject ('they') rather than as an imperative ('appoint'). This would make mercy and truth the subject of the verb, emphasizing how divine attributes actively protect the righteous, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's portrayal of divine attributes as active forces in spiritual realms.

[C] Or: "You shall be blessed more than all peoples" — The Hebrew 'מִכָּל' could be translated as either 'above' or 'more than,' both conveying the comparative blessing promised to Israel. This alternative maintains the comparative aspect while using slightly different phrasing.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this heritage would be understood as both the spiritual rewards awaiting the righteous in the afterlife and the merit of belonging to a lineage of faithful practitioners of Judaism whose traditions provide comfort and guidance during life transitions.

[2] While this verse literally requests long life for the king, in Ma'avar Yabok's context it functions as both a prayer for healing (extended life) and a recognition of the eternal life awaiting the soul after death. This dual meaning makes it particularly appropriate in prayers that acknowledge both possible outcomes of serious illness.

[3] In Jewish tradition, making vows during illness (particularly pledges of charity or increased religious observance in exchange for healing) was common practice. This verse reflects both the ill person's hope for recovery and their commitment to spiritual practices whether in this world or the next.

[i] The "heritage of those who fear Your name" refers to the spiritual inheritance granted to the righteous. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would be understood as the divine reward awaiting those who properly prepare for death through repentance and spiritual practices.

[ii] While literally referring to the king's longevity, in the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves a dual purpose: as a petition for extended life for the ill person and as a reminder of eternal life awaiting the righteous in the World to Come.

[iii] The Hebrew "man" (מַן) is an unusual form meaning "appoint" or "prepare." The pairing of "mercy and truth" (חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת) represents divine attributes that protect and preserve the righteous, a theme that would resonate strongly in prayers for divine protection during illness.

[iv] The fulfillment of vows "day by day" connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation throughout life. In the context of serious illness, this reflects the Jewish practice of making vows for charitable acts or increased religious observance in exchange for healing.

[v] Cf. Psalm 57:1 — The recurring motif of finding refuge under divine wings creates a consistent spiritual framework for those facing illness or death, emphasizing that God's protective presence extends even to the most vulnerable moments of human existence. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The thematic parallels between Psalms 61 and 91 around divine protection suggest why both were included in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences. For the ill person, these texts create a consistent message that God's presence provides shelter during their most vulnerable moments. | Cf. Genesis 28:20 — In Ma'avar Yabok, the psalm's reference to fulfilling vows would remind readers of the biblical precedent of making vows during life transitions, reinforcing the practice of making pledges (often charitable) during illness with the hope of divine protection. | Cf. Zohar III:56a — For readers of Ma'avar Yabok familiar with Kabbalistic literature, the psalm's reference to taking refuge under divine wings would activate associations with the Zohar's teachings about the soul's protection under the Shekhinah's wings, especially during the vulnerable transition from life to death.

הָעַמִּים לֹא יִהְיֶה בְךָ עָקָר
וַעֲקָרָה[i] וּבִבְהֶמְתֶּךָ: וְהֵסִיר יְהוָה
מִמְּךָ כָּל חֹלִי וְכָל מַדְוֵי מִצְרַיִם
הָרָעִים[ii] אֲשֶׁר יָדַעְתָּ לֹא יְשִׂימָם
בָּךְ וּנְתָנָם בְּכָל שֹׂנְאֶיךָ: וְיָדַעְתָּ
עִם לְבָבֶךָ כִּי כַּאֲשֶׁר יִיַּסֵּר אִישׁ
אֶת בְּנוֹ[iii] יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ מְיַסְּרֶךָּ:
וְשָׁמַרְתָּ אֶת חֻקֵּיו וְאֶת מִצְוֹתָיו
אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מְצַוְּךָ הַיּוֹם אֲשֶׁר
יִיטַב לְךָ וּלְבָנֶיךָ אַחֲרֶיךָ וּלְמַעַן
תַּאֲרִיךְ יָמִים[iv] עַל הָאֲדָמָה אֲשֶׁר
יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ נֹתֵן לְךָ כָּל הַיָּמִים:
וְהִתְקַדִּשְׁתֶּם וִהְיִיתֶם קְדֹשִׁים כִּי
אֲנִי יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם: לֹא יַעֲקֹב
יֵאָמֵר עוֹד שִׁמְךָ כִּי אִם יִשְׂרָאֵל[v] כִּי
שָׂרִיתָ עִם אֱלֹהִים וְעִם אֲנָשִׁים
וַתּוּכָל: [vi]

shall not be a barren male or barren female among you or among your cattle. And the LORD will remove from you all sickness and all the terrible diseases of Egypt[A] that you knew; He will not place them upon you, but will put them on all who hate you. And you shall know in your heart that just as a man disciplines his son, so the LORD your God disciplines you.[1] Therefore you shall keep His statutes and His commandments which I command you today, that it may go well with you and with your children after you, and that you may prolong your days on the land which the LORD your God gives you for all time.[2] You shall sanctify yourselves and be holy, for I am the LORD your God. No longer shall your name be called Jacob, but Israel,[3] for you have striven with God and with men, and have prevailed.[B]

[A] Or: "the evil afflictions of Egypt" — The Hebrew 'מַדְוֵי' refers to ailments or afflictions, while 'הָרָעִים' can be translated as 'evil' or 'terrible.' This alternative provides a more literal rendering of the terms while preserving the meaning.

[B] Or: "for you have contended with divine and human beings, and have overcome" — The

[1] This verse provides a theological framework for understanding suffering as potentially redemptive rather than merely punitive. In Ma'avar Yabok, this perspective helps the sick person interpret their illness within a meaningful spiritual narrative.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'כָּל הַיָּמִים' literally means 'all the days' and emphasizes the permanence of God's gift, reinforcing the theme of life extension that would be particularly meaningful in prayers for the sick.

[3] The inclusion of the verse about Jacob becoming Israel is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, whose title references Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok River where this transformation occurred. The struggle with illness is implicitly compared to Jacob's wrestling, suggesting that spiritual transformation may emerge from physical struggle.

[i] This refers specifically to barrenness in males and females, respectively. In the ancient Near Eastern context, fertility was considered one of the most fundamental divine blessings, making this promise particularly significant.

[ii] This refers to the plagues and diseases that afflicted Egypt, which became proverbial in biblical literature as examples of divine punishment. The promise of protection from these conditions would be especially meaningful to someone suffering from serious illness.

[iii] This establishes a parental metaphor for divine discipline that recurs throughout the Hebrew Bible. The comparison suggests that suffering, while painful, may be understood as corrective rather than punitive.

[iv] The promise of 'prolonging days' would be particularly relevant in a context of prayer for healing, as it directly addresses the central concern of extending life.

[v] This verse about Jacob's renaming to Israel after wrestling at the Jabbok River is especially significant given the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok). It suggests that struggle with illness, like Jacob's struggle, can lead to spiritual transformation.

[vi] Cf. Deuteronomy 7:14-15 — These verses from Deuteronomy are being included in this healing prayer sequence to remind the ill person of God's promises of health and blessing to the covenant community. The text establishes biblical precedent for praying for healing by recalling God's promises to remove illness. | Cf. Deuteronomy 8:5 — This verse serves as a theological foundation for understanding illness within Ma'avar Yabok's framework—as divine discipline motivated by love rather than mere punishment. It encourages the sick person to view suffering as potentially redemptive and character-forming. | Cf. Deuteronomy 4:40 — The echoes of Deuteronomy 4:40 suggest that recovery from illness is connected to renewed commitment to observing divine com-

(נביאים) וַיהוָה חָפֵץ דַּכְּאוֹ
הֶחֱלִי אִם תָּשִׂים אָשָׁם נַפְשׁוֹ יִרְאֶה
זֶרַע יַאֲרִיךְ יָמִים וְחֵפֶץ יְהוָה
בְּיָדוֹ יִצְלָח: מֵעֲמַל נַפְשׁוֹ יִרְאֶה יִשְׂבָּע
וְכַשֹּׁרֶשׁ מֵאֶרֶץ צִיָּה לֹא תֹאַר לוֹ
וְלֹא הָדָר וְנִרְאֵהוּ וְלֹא מַרְאֶה
וְנֶחְמְדֵהוּ: וְהוּא מְחֹלָל מִפְּשָׁעֵנוּ
מְדֻכָּא מֵעֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ[i] מוּסַר שְׁלוֹמֵנוּ
עָלָיו וּבַחֲבֻרָתוֹ נִרְפָּא לָנוּ:
נִגַּשׂ וְהוּא נַעֲנֶה וְלֹא יִפְתַּח פִּיו
כַּשֶּׂה לַטֶּבַח יוּבָל וּכְרָחֵל לִפְנֵי
גֹזְזֶיהָ נֶאֱלָמָה[ii] וְלֹא יִפְתַּח פִּיו:
דְּרָכָיו רָאִיתִי וְאֶרְפָּאֵהוּ וַאֲנַחֵהוּ

(From Prophets) And the LORD was pleased to crush him, making him ill; if you make his soul a guilt offering,[A1] he shall see offspring, prolong his days, and the will of the LORD shall prosper in his hand. He grew up before Him like a tender shoot, like a root from dry ground. He had no form or majesty that we should look at him,[2] no appearance that we should desire him. He was pierced for our transgressions,[B] crushed for our iniquities; the chastisement for our peace was upon him,[C] and by his wounds we are healed.[3] He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth; like a lamb led to slaughter,[4] and like a sheep silent before

Hebrew 'שָׂרִיתָ' means to struggle or contend with, and this alternative uses 'contended' instead of 'striven' while also rendering 'אֱלֹהִים' as 'divine beings' rather than simply 'God' to reflect potential ambiguity in the original. 'Overcome' offers a slight variation on 'prevailed.'

[A]Or: "his life as a reparation offering" — 'Asham' specifically refers to a reparation offering in the Temple sacrificial system, which had precise ritual requirements. 'Life' may be preferred over 'soul' for 'nefesh' in this context as it relates to physical sacrifice.

[B]Or: "He was wounded for our transgressions" — The Hebrew 'mecholal' can be translated as either 'pierced' or 'wounded.' While 'pierced' conveys the violence of the imagery more dramatically, 'wounded' might be preferred for a more neutral scholarly translation less influenced by specific theological interpretations.

[C]Or: "the discipline for our wholeness was upon him" — 'Shalom' encompasses more than just 'peace' and includes concepts of wholeness, completeness, and well-being. 'Discipline' might be preferred over 'chastisement' as it better reflects the Hebrew 'musar' which carries connotations of instruction and correction, not merely punishment.

[1]The Hebrew 'asham' refers specifically to a guilt offering in the Temple sacrificial system. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this sacrificial language would be interpreted as describing how the suffering of the righteous can function as a form of atonement, connecting physical illness to spiritual purification.

[2]This description of the suffering servant's unremarkable appearance parallels how illness often diminishes physical beauty and strength. In Ma'avar Yabok's framework, this would suggest that spiritual value transcends physical appearance, particularly relevant for comforting the physically diminished ill.

[3]This paradoxical statement about healing coming through wounds reflects Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework where suffering, properly endured, can lead to spiritual healing and elevation.

[4]This powerful metaphor would be particularly resonant in the context of terminal illness, where Ma'avar Yabok encourages acceptance of divine judgment with dignity and silence.

mandments. This reinforces Ma'avar Yabok's consistent emphasis on repentance and renewed observance as part of the healing process. | Cf. Leviticus 20:7 — This verse connects physical healing to spiritual purification, suggesting that sanctification is both a prerequisite for and result of divine healing. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this encourages the sick person toward spiritual renewal. | Cf. Genesis 32:28 — The inclusion of this verse is particularly significant given the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok). It draws a parallel between the sick person's struggle with illness and Jacob's transformative spiritual struggle, suggesting that the current ordeal may lead to spiritual elevation and a new identity.

[i]This verse from Isaiah 53:5 is central to the 'Suffering Servant' passage, which has been interpreted in various ways in Jewish tradition. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would be understood as expressing how the righteous may suffer as atonement not only for their own sins but potentially for others, a concept that gives spiritual meaning to suffering.

[ii]This powerful metaphor comparing the suffering servant to silent animals led to slaughter would resonate particularly in the context of illness and approaching death, where the sick person might be encouraged to accept suffering with dignified silence and submission to divine will.

וְאַשְׁלֵם נִחֻמִים לוֹ וְלַאֲבֵלָיו: כִּי
רִבּוּ פְשָׁעֵינוּ נֶגְדֶּךָ וְחַטֹּאותֵינוּ
עָנְתָה בָּנוּ כִּי פָשָׁעֵינוּ אִתָּנוּ
וַעֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ יְדַעֲנוּם: וַאֲנִי זֹאת
בָּרִיתִי אוֹתָם[i] אָמַר יְהוָה רוּחִי
אֲשֶׁר עָלֶיךָ וּדְבָרַי אֲשֶׁר שַׂמְתִּי
בְּפִיךָ לֹא יָמוּשׁוּ מִפִּיךָ וּמִפִּי
זַרְעֲךָ וּמִפִּי זֶרַע זַרְעֲךָ אָמַר יְהוָה
מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם: קוּמִי אוֹרִי כִּי
בָא אוֹרֵךְ[ii] וּכְבוֹד יְהוָה עָלַיִךְ
זָרָח: כִּי הִנֵּה הַחֹשֶׁךְ יְכַסֶּה אֶרֶץ
וַעֲרָפֶל לְאֻמִּים וְעָלַיִךְ יִזְרַח יְהוָה
וּכְבוֹדוֹ עָלַיִךְ יֵרָאֶה: וְהָלְכוּ גוֹיִם לְאוֹרֵךְ
וּמְלָכִים לְנֹגַהּ זַרְחֵךְ: שְׂאִי סָבִיב עֵינַיִךְ
וּרְאִי כֻּלָּם נִקְבְּצוּ בָאוּ לָךְ בָּנַיִךְ
מֵרָחוֹק יָבוֹאוּ וּבְנוֹתַיִךְ עַל צַד תֵּאָמַנָה:
אָז תִּרְאִי וְנָהַרְתְּ וְפָחַד וְרָחַב לְבָבֵךְ
כִּי יֵהָפֵךְ עָלַיִךְ הֲמוֹן יָם חֵיל גּוֹיִם
יָבֹאוּ לָךְ: שִׁפְעַת גְּמַלִּים תְּכַסֵּךְ
בִּכְרֵי מִדְיָן וְעֵיפָה כֻּלָּם מִשְּׁבָא יָבֹאוּ
זָהָב וּלְבוֹנָה יִשָּׂאוּ וּתְהִלֹּת יְהוָה יְבַשֵּׂרוּ:
כָּל צֹאן קֵדָר יִקָּבְצוּ לָךְ אֵילֵי נְבָיוֹת
יְשָׁרְתוּנֵךְ יַעֲלוּ עַל רָצוֹן מִזְבְּחִי
וּבֵית תִּפְאַרְתִּי אֲפָאֵר: מִי אֵלֶּה כָּעָב תָּעוּפֶינָה
וּכְיוֹנִים אֶל אֲרֻבֹּתֵיהֶם: כִּי לִי אִיִּים יְקַוּוּ
וְאֳנִיּוֹת תַּרְשִׁישׁ בָּרִאשֹׁנָה לְהָבִיא בָנַיִךְ
מֵרָחוֹק כַּסְפָּם וְזְהָבָם אִתָּם לְשֵׁם יְהוָה
אֱלֹהָיִךְ וְלִקְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל כִּי פֵאֲרֵךְ:
וּבָנוּ בְנֵי נֵכָר חֹמֹתַיִךְ וּמַלְכֵיהֶם יְשָׁרְתוּנֵךְ
כִּי בְקִצְפִּי הִכִּיתִיךְ וּבְרְצוֹנִי רִחַמְתִּיךְ:
וְפָתְחוּ שְׁעָרַיִךְ תָּמִיד יוֹמָם וָלַיְלָה לֹא יִסָּגֵרוּ
לְהָבִיא אֵלַיִךְ חֵיל גּוֹיִם וּמַלְכֵיהֶם נְהוּגִים:
כִּי הַגּוֹי וְהַמַּמְלָכָה אֲשֶׁר לֹא יַעַבְדוּךְ יֹאבֵדוּ
וְהַגּוֹיִם חָרֹב יֶחֱרָבוּ: כְּבוֹד לְבָנוֹן אֵלַיִךְ יָבוֹא
בְּרוֹשׁ תְּאַשּׁוּר וְתִדְהָר יַחְדָּו לְפָאֵר מְקוֹם מִקְדָּשִׁי
וּמְקוֹם רַגְלַי אֲכַבֵּד: וְהָלְכוּ אֵלַיִךְ שְׁחוּחֵי
וְכֹל מְנַאֲצַיִךְ יִכְרְעוּ עַל כַּפוֹת רַגְלָיִךְ
וְקָרְאוּ לָךְ עִיר יְהוָה צִיּוֹן קְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל:
תַּחַת הֱיוֹתֵךְ עֲזוּבָה וּשְׂנוּאָה וְאֵין עוֹבֵר
וְשַׂמְתִּיךְ לִגְאוֹן עוֹלָם מְשׂוֹשׂ דּוֹר וָדוֹר:
וְיָנַקְתְּ חֲלֵב גּוֹיִם וְשַׁד מְלָכִים תִּינָקִי
וְיָדַעַתְּ כִּי אֲנִי יְהוָה מוֹשִׁיעֵךְ וְגֹאֲלֵךְ
אֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב: תַּחַת הַנְּחוּשָׁה אָבִיא זָהָב
וְתַחַת הַבַּרְזֶל אָבִיא כֶּסֶף וְתַחַת הָעֵצִים נְחֹשֶׁת
וְתַחַת הָאֲבָנִים בַּרְזֶל וְשַׂמְתִּי פְקֻדָּתֵךְ
שָׁלוֹם וְנֹגְשַׂיִךְ צְדָקָה: לֹא יִשָּׁמַע עוֹד חָמָס
בְּאַרְצֵךְ שֹׁד וָשֶׁבֶר בִּגְבוּלָיִךְ וְקָרָאתְ יְשׁוּעָה
חוֹמֹתַיִךְ וּשְׁעָרַיִךְ תְּהִלָּה: לֹא יִהְיֶה לָּךְ עוֹד
הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ לְאוֹר יוֹמָם וּלְנֹגַהּ הַיָּרֵחַ לֹא יָאִיר לָךְ
וְהָיָה יְהוָה לְךָ לְאוֹר עוֹלָם וֵאלֹהַיִךְ לְתִפְאַרְתֵּךְ:
לֹא יָבוֹא עוֹד שִׁמְשֵׁךְ וִירֵחֵךְ לֹא יֵאָסֵף
כִּי יְהוָה יִהְיֶה לְךָ לְאוֹר עוֹלָם וְשָׁלְמוּ יְמֵי אֶבְלֵךְ:
וְעַמֵּךְ כֻּלָּם צַדִּיקִים לְעוֹלָם יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ
נֵצֶר מַטָּעַי מַעֲשֵׂה יָדַי לְהִתְפָּאֵר: הַקָּטֹן יִהְיֶה
לָאֶלֶף וְהַצָּעִיר לְגוֹי עָצוּם אֲנִי יְהוָה בְּעִתָּהּ
אָחִישֶׁנָּה: רוּחַ אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה עָלָי יַעַן מָשַׁח יְהוָה
אֹתִי לְבַשֵּׂר עֲנָוִים שְׁלָחַנִי לַחֲבֹשׁ לְנִשְׁבְּרֵי לֵב
לִקְרֹא לִשְׁבוּיִם דְּרוֹר וְלַאֲסוּרִים פְּקַח קוֹחַ:
לִקְרֹא שְׁנַת רָצוֹן לַיהוָה וְיוֹם נָקָם לֵאלֹהֵינוּ
לְנַחֵם כָּל אֲבֵלִים: לָשׂוּם לַאֲבֵלֵי צִיּוֹן לָתֶת לָהֶם
פְּאֵר תַּחַת אֵפֶר שֶׁמֶן שָׂשׂוֹן תַּחַת אֲבֵל מַעֲטֵה
תְהִלָּה תַּחַת רוּחַ כֵּהָה וְנִקְרְאוּ לָהֶם אֵילֵי הַצֶּדֶק
מַטַּע יְהוָה לְהִתְפָּאֵר: וּבָנוּ חָרְבוֹת עוֹלָם
שֹׁמְמוֹת רִאשֹׁנִים יָקִימוּ וְחָדְשׁוּ עָרִים נְשַׁמּוֹת
דֹּר וָדֹר: וְעָמְדוּ זָרִים וְרָעוּ צֹאנְכֶם וּבְנֵי נֵכָר
אִכָּרֵיכֶם וְכֹרְמֵיכֶם: וְאַתֶּם כֹּהֲנֵי יְהוָה תֵּאָמֵרוּ
מְשָׁרְתֵי אֱלֹהֵינוּ יֵאָמֵר לָכֶם חֵיל גּוֹיִם תֹּאכֵלוּ
וּבִכְבוֹדָם תִּתְיַמָּרוּ: תַּחַת בָּשְׁתְּכֶם מִשְׁנֶה
וְכְלִמָּה יָרְנוּ חֶלְקָם לָכֵן בְּאַרְצָם מִשְׁנֶה יִירָשׁוּ
שִׂמְחַת עוֹלָם תִּהְיֶה לָהֶם: כִּי אֲנִי יְהוָה אֹהֵב
מִשְׁפָּט שֹׂנֵא גָזֵל בְּעוֹלָה וְנָתַתִּי פְעֻלָּתָם בֶּאֱמֶת
וּבְרִית עוֹלָם אכרות לָהֶם: וְנוֹדַע בַּגּוֹיִם זַרְעָם
וְצֶאֱצָאֵיהֶם בְּתוֹךְ הָעַמִּים כָּל רֹאֵיהֶם יַכִּירוּם
כִּי הֵם זֶרַע בֵּרַךְ יְהוָה: שׂוֹשׂ אָשִׂישׂ בַּיהוָה
תָּגֵל נַפְשִׁי בֵּאלֹהַי כִּי הִלְבִּישַׁנִי בִּגְדֵי יֶשַׁע
מְעִיל צְדָקָה יְעָטָנִי כֶּחָתָן יְכַהֵן פְּאֵר וְכַכַּלָּה
תַּעְדֶּה כֵּלֶיהָ: כִּי כְאֶרֶץ תּוֹצִיא צִמְחָהּ
וּכְגִנָּה זְרוּעֶיהָ תַּצְמִיחֶ כֵּן אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה יַצְמִיחַ
צְדָקָה וּתְהִלָּה נֶגֶד כָּל גּוֹיִם:

וַאֲשַׁלֵּם נִחֻמִים לוֹ וְלַאֲבֵלָיו: כִּי
רִבּוּ פְשָׁעֵינוּ נֶגְדֶּךָ וְחַטֹּאותֵינוּ
עָנְתָה בָּנוּ כִּי פָשָׁעֵינוּ אִתָּנוּ
וַעֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ יְדַעֲנוּם: וַאֲנִי זֹאת
בָּרִיתִי אוֹתָם[i] אָמַר יְהוָה רוּחִי
אֲשֶׁר עָלֶיךָ וּדְבָרַי אֲשֶׁר שַׂמְתִּי
בְּפִיךָ לֹא יָמוּשׁוּ מִפִּיךָ וּמִפִּי
זַרְעֲךָ וּמִפִּי זֶרַע זַרְעֲךָ אָמַר יְהוָה
מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם: קוּמִי אוֹרִי כִּי
בָא אוֹרֵךְ[ii] וּכְבוֹד יְהוָה עָלַיִךְ
זָרָח: כִּי הִנֵּה הַחֹשֶׁךְ יְכַסֶּה אֶרֶץ
וַעֲרָפֶל לְאֻמִּים וְעָלַיִךְ יִזְרַח יְהוָה
וּכְבוֹדוֹ עָלַיִךְ יֵרָאֶה: וְהָלְכוּ גוֹיִם לְאוֹרֵךְ
וּמְלָכִים לְנֹגַהּ זַרְחֵךְ: שְׂאִי סָבִיב עֵינַיִךְ
וּרְאִי כֻּלָּם נִקְבְּצוּ בָאוּ לָךְ בָּנַיִךְ
מֵרָחוֹק יָבוֹאוּ וּבְנוֹתַיִךְ עַל צַד תֵּאָמַנָה:
אָז תִּרְאִי וְנָהַרְתְּ וְפָחַד וְרָחַב לְבָבֵךְ
כִּי יֵהָפֵךְ עָלַיִךְ הֲמוֹן יָם חֵיל גּוֹיִם
יָבֹאוּ לָךְ: שִׁפְעַת גְּמַלִּים תְּכַסֵּךְ
בִּכְרֵי מִדְיָן וְעֵיפָה כֻּלָּם מִשְּׁבָא יָבֹאוּ
זָהָב וּלְבוֹנָה יִשָּׂאוּ וּתְהִלֹּת יְהוָה יְבַשֵּׂרוּ:
כָּל צֹאן קֵדָר יִקָּבְצוּ לָךְ אֵילֵי נְבָיוֹת
יְשָׁרְתוּנֵךְ יַעֲלוּ עַל רָצוֹן מִזְבְּחִי
וּבֵית תִּפְאַרְתִּי אֲפָאֵר: מִי אֵלֶּה כָּעָב תָּעוּפֶינָה
וּכְיוֹנִים אֶל אֲרֻבֹּתֵיהֶם: כִּי לִי אִיִּים יְקַוּוּ
וְאֳנִיּוֹת תַּרְשִׁישׁ בָּרִאשֹׁנָה לְהָבִיא בָנַיִךְ
מֵרָחוֹק כַּסְפָּם וְזְהָבָם אִתָּם לְשֵׁם יְהוָה
אֱלֹהָיִךְ וְלִקְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל כִּי פֵאֲרֵךְ:
וּבָנוּ בְנֵי נֵכָר חֹמֹתַיִךְ וּמַלְכֵיהֶם יְשָׁרְתוּנֵךְ
כִּי בְקִצְפִּי הִכִּיתִיךְ וּבְרְצוֹנִי רִחַמְתִּיךְ:
וְפָתְחוּ שְׁעָרַיִךְ תָּמִיד יוֹמָם וָלַיְלָה לֹא יִסָּגֵרוּ
לְהָבִיא אֵלַיִךְ חֵיל גּוֹיִם וּמַלְכֵיהֶם נְהוּגִים:
כִּי הַגּוֹי וְהַמַּמְלָכָה אֲשֶׁר לֹא יַעַבְדוּךְ יֹאבֵדוּ
וְהַגּוֹיִם חָרֹב יֶחֱרָבוּ: כְּבוֹד לְבָנוֹן אֵלַיִךְ יָבוֹא
בְּרוֹשׁ תְּאַשּׁוּר וְתִדְהָר יַחְדָּו לְפָאֵר מְקוֹם מִקְדָּשִׁי
וּמְקוֹם רַגְלַי אֲכַבֵּד: וְהָלְכוּ אֵלַיִךְ שְׁחוּחֵי
וְכֹל מְנַאֲצַיִךְ יִכְרְעוּ עַל כַּפוֹת רַגְלָיִךְ
וְקָרְאוּ לָךְ עִיר יְהוָה צִיּוֹן קְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל:
תַּחַת הֱיוֹתֵךְ עֲזוּבָה וּשְׂנוּאָה וְאֵין עוֹבֵר
וְשַׂמְתִּיךְ לִגְאוֹן עוֹלָם מְשׂוֹשׂ דּוֹר וָדוֹר:
וְיָנַקְתְּ חֲלֵב גּוֹיִם וְשַׁד מְלָכִים תִּינָקִי
וְיָדַעַתְּ כִּי אֲנִי יְהוָה מוֹשִׁיעֵךְ וְגֹאֲלֵךְ
אֲבִיר יַעֲקֹב: תַּחַת הַנְּחוּשָׁה אָבִיא זָהָב
וְתַחַת הַבַּרְזֶל אָבִיא כֶּסֶף וְתַחַת הָעֵצִים נְחֹשֶׁת
וְתַחַת הָאֲבָנִים בַּרְזֶל וְשַׂמְתִּי פְקֻדָּתֵךְ
שָׁלוֹם וְנֹגְשַׂיִךְ צְדָקָה: לֹא יִשָּׁמַע עוֹד חָמָס
בְּאַרְצֵךְ שֹׁד וָשֶׁבֶר בִּגְבוּלָיִךְ וְקָרָאתְ יְשׁוּעָה
חוֹמֹתַיִךְ וּשְׁעָרַיִךְ תְּהִלָּה: לֹא יִהְיֶה לָּךְ עוֹד
הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ לְאוֹר יוֹמָם וּלְנֹגַהּ הַיָּרֵחַ לֹא יָאִיר לָךְ
וְהָיָה יְהוָה לְךָ לְאוֹר עוֹלָם וֵאלֹהַיִךְ לְתִפְאַרְתֵּךְ:
לֹא יָבוֹא עוֹד שִׁמְשֵׁךְ וִירֵחֵךְ לֹא יֵאָסֵף
כִּי יְהוָה יִהְיֶה לְךָ לְאוֹר עוֹלָם וְשָׁלְמוּ יְמֵי אֶבְלֵךְ:
וְעַמֵּךְ כֻּלָּם צַדִּיקִים לְעוֹלָם יִירְשׁוּ אָרֶץ
נֵצֶר מַטָּעַי מַעֲשֵׂה יָדַי לְהִתְפָּאֵר: הַקָּטֹן יִהְיֶה
לָאֶלֶף וְהַצָּעִיר לְגוֹי עָצוּם אֲנִי יְהוָה בְּעִתָּהּ
אָחִישֶׁנָּה: רוּחַ אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה עָלָי יַעַן מָשַׁח יְהוָה
אֹתִי לְבַשֵּׂר עֲנָוִים שְׁלָחַנִי לַחֲבֹשׁ לְנִשְׁבְּרֵי לֵב
לִקְרֹא לִשְׁבוּיִם דְּרוֹר וְלַאֲסוּרִים פְּקַח קוֹחַ:
לִקְרֹא שְׁנַת רָצוֹן לַיהוָה וְיוֹם נָקָם לֵאלֹהֵינוּ
לְנַחֵם כָּל אֲבֵלִים: לָשׂוּם לַאֲבֵלֵי צִיּוֹן לָתֶת לָהֶם
פְּאֵר תַּחַת אֵפֶר שֶׁמֶן שָׂשׂוֹן תַּחַת אֲבֵל מַעֲטֵה
תְהִלָּה תַּחַת רוּחַ כֵּהָה וְנִקְרְאוּ לָהֶם אֵילֵי הַצֶּדֶק
מַטַּע יְהוָה לְהִתְפָּאֵר: וּבָנוּ חָרְבוֹת עוֹלָם
שֹׁמְמוֹת רִאשֹׁנִים יָקִימוּ וְחָדְשׁוּ עָרִים נְשַׁמּוֹת
דֹּר וָדֹר: וְעָמְדוּ זָרִים וְרָעוּ צֹאנְכֶם וּבְנֵי נֵכָר
אִכָּרֵיכֶם וְכֹרְמֵיכֶם: וְאַתֶּם כֹּהֲנֵי יְהוָה תֵּאָמֵרוּ
מְשָׁרְתֵי אֱלֹהֵינוּ יֵאָמֵר לָכֶם חֵיל גּוֹיִם תֹּאכֵלוּ
וּבִכְבוֹדָם תִּתְיַמָּרוּ: תַּחַת בָּשְׁתְּכֶם מִשְׁנֶה
וְכְלִמָּה יָרְנוּ חֶלְקָם לָכֵן בְּאַרְצָם מִשְׁנֶה יִירָשׁוּ
שִׂמְחַת עוֹלָם תִּהְיֶה לָהֶם: כִּי אֲנִי יְהוָה אֹהֵב
מִשְׁפָּט שֹׂנֵא גָזֵל בְּעוֹלָה וְנָתַתִּי פְעֻלָּתָם בֶּאֱמֶת
וּבְרִית עוֹלָם אכרות לָהֶם: וְנוֹדַע בַּגּוֹיִם זַרְעָם
וְצֶאֱצָאֵיהֶם בְּתוֹךְ הָעַמִּים כָּל רֹאֵיהֶם יַכִּירוּם
כִּי הֵם זֶרַע בֵּרַךְ יְהוָה: שׂוֹשׂ אָשִׂישׂ בַּיהוָה
תָּגֵל נַפְשִׁי בֵּאלֹהַי כִּי הִלְבִּישַׁנִי בִּגְדֵי יֶשַׁע
מְעִיל צְדָקָה יְעָטָנִי כֶּחָתָן יְכַהֵן פְּאֵר וְכַכַּלָּה
תַּעְדֶּה כֵּלֶיהָ: כִּי כְאֶרֶץ תּוֹצִיא צִמְחָהּ
וּכְגִנָּה זְרוּעֶיהָ תַּצְמִיחֶ כֵּן אֲדֹנָי יְהוִה יַצְמִיחַ
צְדָקָה וּתְהִלָּה נֶגֶד כָּל גּוֹיִם:

its shearers, he did not open his mouth. I have seen his ways, and I will heal him;[A] I will guide him and restore comfort to him and to his mourners.[1] For our transgressions have multiplied before You, and our sins testify against us; for our transgressions are with us, and we know our iniquities. "As for Me, this is My covenant with them," says the LORD: "My Spirit that is upon you, and My words that I have put in your mouth, shall not depart from your mouth, nor from the mouth of your offspring, nor from the mouth of your offspring's offspring," says the LORD, "from now and forever." Arise, shine, for your light has come,[2] and the glory of the LORD has risen upon you. For behold, darkness shall cover the earth, and thick darkness the peoples; but the LORD will arise upon you, and His glory will appear over you. Instead of bronze I will bring gold,[3] and instead of iron I will bring silver; instead of wood, bronze, and instead of stones, iron. I will make your overseers peace and your taskmasters righteousness. Look down from heaven and see, from Your holy and glorious habitation. Where are Your zeal and Your might? The stirring of Your heart and Your

1130R 1135R 1140R 1145R

[A] Or: "I have observed his ways, and I will heal him" — The Hebrew 'ra'iti' means 'I have seen' but in this context implies more than just visual perception, but rather an assessment or evaluation of behavior. 'Observed' might better capture this nuance.

[1] This divine promise of comfort extends not only to the suffering individual but also to those who mourn with them, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's concern for both the ill person and their community of caregivers.

[2] This transformative command represents the hope for both physical recovery and spiritual illumination, which in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework are interconnected aspects of divine healing.

[3] This series of divine transformations symbolizes how suffering can be transmuted into spiritual elevation, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness as a potentially purifying experience.

[i] This verse marks a transition from confession of sins to divine reassurance, following the pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok where acknowledgment of human failing is balanced with affirmation of divine mercy and covenant promises.

[ii] This familiar verse from Isaiah 60 introduces light imagery that contrasts with the previous focus on suffering. In the context of prayers for healing, this would represent hope for recovery and spiritual illumination emerging from the darkness of illness.

[iii] This metaphor of divine transformation of lesser materials into precious ones would be interpreted in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework as representing how physical suffering can be spiritually elevated, turning the 'bronze' of affliction into the 'gold' of spiritual refinement.

[iv] This appeal to God's parental relationship with Israel creates an intimate framework for the prayer, suggesting that divine compassion, like that of a father, will ultimately prevail over judgment.

[v] Cf. Isaiah 53:10-11 — This passage from Isaiah's 'Suffering Servant' text is incorporated into the prayer sequence for healing the sick in Ma'avar Yabok. In the original biblical context, it describes a righteous figure who suffers on behalf of others. In the liturgical context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses would be recited to provide spiritual comfort to the ill person, connecting

compassion are withheld from me.[1] For You are our Father, though Abraham does not know us and Israel does not recognize us. You, O LORD, are our Father, our Redeemer from of old is Your name.[2] 1150R

(כתובים) הַקְשִׁיבָה לִי
וַעֲנֵנִי[i] אָרִיד בְּשִׂיחִי וְאָהִימָה:[ii] אֲנִי
אֶל אֱלֹהִים אֶקְרָא וַיהוָה יוֹשִׁיעֵנִי:
עֶרֶב וָבֹקֶר וְצָהֳרַיִם אָשִׂיחָה

(Writings) Listen to me and answer me; I am restless in my complaint and I moan.[A] I call to God, and the LORD saves me.[3] Evening, morning, and noon I speak and lament,[B] and He hears my voice. In God 1155R

[A] Or: "I wander in my meditation and am troubled" — The Hebrew 'arid' can suggest wandering or roaming thoughts, while 'ahimah' conveys being troubled or disturbed. This alternate captures the mental distress rather than physical restlessness.

[B] Or: "Evening, morning, and noon I meditate and moan" — The term 'asichah' often refers to meditation or contemplative prayer rather than ordinary speech, which better fits the context of prayerful communication with God at the traditional Jewish prayer times.

[1] This expression of feeling divine abandonment would resonate with the seriously ill while still maintaining a framework of appeal to God as Father, preserving hope even in apparent divine absence.

[2] The prayer concludes by invoking God as Redeemer, emphasizing divine redemptive power that transcends current suffering, consistent with Ma'avar Yabok's framework of finding meaning and hope in illness.

[3] The text uses both divine names Elohim (God) and YHVH (the LORD), creating a parallel structure that emphasizes the completeness of divine response to human prayer. This pattern appears frequently in biblical poetry.

their suffering to a divine purpose of purification and spiritual elevation. | Cf. Isaiah 57:18 — This verse expressing divine healing and comfort would be particularly meaningful in a prayer for the sick. Its inclusion in this liturgical sequence reinforces Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that illness can be a path to spiritual purification followed by divine comfort and restoration. | Cf. Isaiah 59:12 — This verse fits with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession (vidui) as an essential component of spiritual healing. In the context of prayers for the sick, this acknowledgment of transgressions would be seen as facilitating divine forgiveness and healing. | Cf. Isaiah 59:21 — This verse of divine reassurance would provide comfort to the sick by affirming God's eternal covenant with Israel. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, it would reassure the ill person of continued divine presence and guidance regardless of their physical condition. | Cf. Isaiah 60:1-2 — These verses metaphorically transform darkness into light, mirroring the desired transformation from illness to health. In Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, this would represent the spiritual illumination that can emerge from the darkness of suffering. | Cf. Isaiah 60:17 — This verse's promise of transformation would be particularly meaningful in prayers for healing, symbolizing how suffering can be transformed into spiritual elevation. It aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's view that illness, properly approached, can lead to spiritual refinement. | Cf. Isaiah 63:15-16 — These verses appeal to God's parental compassion, which would be particularly appropriate in prayers for the sick. They emphasize the intimate relationship between God and the supplicant, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's theme that proper prayer creates a direct channel to divine mercy. | Cf. The Zohar — The selection of these particular prophetic passages reflects the kabbalistic approach of Ma'avar Yabok, which draws heavily on the Zohar. The text's focus on transformation, divine covenant, and the relationship between suffering and spiritual elevation aligns with Zoharic interpretations of illness and healing.

[i] The passage begins with the heading 'Ketuvim' (Writings), indicating that this is a collection of verses from the third section of the Hebrew Bible. This organizational structure follows Ma'avar Yabok's pattern of arranging biblical verses by their source (Torah, Prophets, Writings) within each prayer sequence.

[ii] The Hebrew 'arid' suggests wandering or restless thoughts, while 'ahimah' conveys being troubled or moaning. Together they express the profound spiritual and emotional distress that illness often brings, combining both mental anguish and physical discomfort.

וְאֶהֱמָה[i] וַיִּשְׁמַע קוֹלִי: בֵּאלֹהִים
אֲהַלֵּל דָּבָר בַּיהוָה אֲהַלֵּל דָּבָר:
כִּי הִצַּלְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מָמָוֶת הֲלֹא רַגְלַי
מִדֶּחִי לְהִתְהַלֵּךְ לִפְנֵי אֱלֹהִים
בְּאוֹר הַחַיִּים:[ii] וַאֲנִי אָשִׁיר עֻזֶּךָ
וַאֲרַנֵּן לַבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ כִּי הָיִיתָ
מִשְׂגָּב לִי וּמָנוֹס בְּיוֹם צַר לִי: שָׁמַע
אֱלֹהִים קוֹלִי בְשִׂיחִי מִפַּחַד אוֹיֵב
תִּצֹּר חַיָּי: תַּסְתִּירֵנִי מִסּוֹד מְרֵעִים
מֵרִגְשַׁת פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן: הַשָּׁם נַפְשֵׁנוּ
בַּחַיִּים וְלֹא נָתַן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֵנוּ: חָנֵּנִי
אֱלֹהִים חָנֵּנִי כִּי בְךָ חָסְיָה נַפְשִׁי
וּבְצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ אֶחְסֶה עַד יַעֲבֹר
הַוּוֹת:[iii] אֵךְ אֶל אֱלֹהִים דּוֹמִיָּה
נַפְשִׁי מִמֶּנּוּ יְשׁוּעָתִי: אַךְ לֵאלֹהִים
דּוֹמִי נַפְשִׁי כִּי מִמֶּנּוּ תִקְוָתִי: אַךְ
הוּא צוּרִי וְיִשׁוּעָתִי מִשְׂגַּבִּי לֹא
אֶמּוֹט: עַל אֱלֹהִים יִשְׁעִי וּכְבוֹדִי
צוּר עֻזִּי מַחְסִי בֵּאלֹהִים: אִמְרוּ שָׁמַע
אֱלֹהִים הִקְשִׁיב בְּקוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי:
בָּרוּךְ אֲדֹנָי יוֹם יוֹם יַעֲמָס לָנוּ
הָאֵל יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ סֶלָה: וַאֲנִי תְּפִלָּתִי

I praise His word, in the LORD I praise His word.
For You have delivered my soul from death,[1] indeed,
my feet from stumbling, that I may walk before God 1160R
in the light of life. And I will sing of Your strength,
and rejoice in the morning of Your lovingkindness,
for You have been my stronghold and a refuge in the
day of my distress. Hear, O God, my voice in my
meditation; preserve my life from fear of the enemy. 1165R
Hide me from the secret counsel of evildoers, from
the tumult of workers of iniquity.[A] He who sets our
soul among the living, and has not allowed our foot
to slip. Be gracious to me, O God, be gracious to me,
for my soul takes refuge in You; and in the shadow 1170R
of Your wings I will take refuge[2] until destruction
passes by.[B] My soul is silent before God alone;[3] from
Him comes my salvation. Only toward God is my
soul silent, for from Him comes my hope. He alone
is my rock and my salvation, my stronghold; I shall 1175R
not be moved. Upon God rests my salvation and
my glory; the rock of my strength, my refuge is in
God. Surely God has heard; He has attended to the
voice of my prayer. Blessed be the Lord, day by day

[A] Or: "from the commotion of evildoers" — The Hebrew 'rigshat' refers to a noisy gathering or commotion, which might be more precise than 'tumult' which suggests greater disorder.

[B] Or: "until calamities pass by" — The Hebrew 'havot' is plural in form and often refers to multiple calamities or disasters rather than a single destructive event, which better reflects the ongoing tribulations the psalmist faces.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences for the sick and dying, this phrase takes on additional significance. It can be understood as referring to physical recovery from life-threatening illness, spiritual salvation regardless of physical outcome, or divine deliverance of the soul after death.

[2] This powerful protective imagery appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. In kabbalistic interpretation, the 'wings' represent aspects of divine mercy that shelter the vulnerable soul, particularly during transitions like illness and death.

[3] The Hebrew 'dumiyah' (silence/stillness) suggests not merely absence of speech but a profound state of receptive contemplation and trust. In the context of serious illness, this represents the ideal spiritual posture—complete surrender to divine will beyond verbal expression.

[i] This reference to praying three times daily (evening, morning, and noon) corresponds to the traditional Jewish prayer times of Ma'ariv, Shacharit, and Minchah. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this emphasizes maintaining regular prayer cycles even during illness.

[ii] The phrase 'in the light of life' (b'or hachayim) has multiple meanings in this context: it can refer to continued physical life (recovery from illness), spiritual illumination in this world, or the divine light experienced by the soul after death—all relevant to Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the transition between life and death.

[iii] The Hebrew 'havot' (calamities/destruction) appears in plural form, suggesting that the distress of illness is viewed as one of multiple tribulations that will eventually pass. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's perspective that even serious illness is a transitional state rather than a permanent condition.

לְךָ יְהוָה עֵת רָצוֹן אֱלֹהִים בְּרָב חַסְדֶּךָ עֲנֵנִי בֶּאֱמֶת יִשְׁעֶךָ: בָּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר לֹא הֵסִיר תְּפִלָּתִי וְחַסְדּוֹ מֵאִתִּי: [i]

He bears our burden,[A1] God is our salvation. Selah. But as for me, my prayer is to You, O LORD, at a time of favor; O God, in the abundance of Your lovingkindness, answer me with the truth of Your salvation. Blessed be God, who has not removed my prayer or His lovingkindness from me. 1180R 1185R

ואחר כך יאמר למען יחלצון ידידיך וגומר[ii] רפאני ה׳ וגומר[iii] בכל הסדר הכתוב לעיל [v] [iv] עד צורי וגואלי׳

After this he shall say[2] "That Your beloved ones may be delivered" etc., "Heal me, O LORD" etc., according to the entire order written above,[3] until "my Rock and my Redeemer."

[vi] סדר ו

Order Six 1190R

[A] Or: "He loads us with benefits" — The Hebrew 'ya'amos lanu' can be interpreted positively as God loading us with benefits or blessings, rather than bearing our burdens. This alternate reading is found in some traditional Jewish interpretations.

[1] The Hebrew verb 'ya'amos' has been variously interpreted as 'bears our burden' or 'loads us with benefits.' In the context of illness, both readings are meaningful: God supports us through suffering while also bestowing blessings even amid distress.

[2] This is a standard liturgical instruction in Ma'avar Yabok that appears in each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim), directing the reader to recite the same concluding prayers after each sequence.

[3] This instruction demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok creates a systematic structure for prayer, with standardized elements that are repeated across different healing prayer sequences to create consistency in ritual practice.

[i] Cf. Psalm 55 — These verses from Psalm 55 were selected for inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences because they express the emotional journey from distress to divine trust that the sick or dying person might experience, while emphasizing regular prayer as a source of comfort. | Cf. Psalm 57 — This metaphor of divine protection is particularly powerful in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as it portrays God as sheltering the vulnerable soul of the sick or dying person, creating a sacred space of protection during times of extreme vulnerability. | Cf. Psalm 62 — The selection of these verses emphasizes the spiritual value of silent contemplation and complete trust in God during illness or approaching death. The repetition of 'only' or 'surely' (akh) creates a rhythmic meditation on divine dependability when all else fails. | Cf. Psalm 56 — This verse would be read in Ma'avar Yabok's context as expressing both the hope for physical recovery (walking again) and spiritual salvation (walking in divine light after death), making it particularly appropriate for prayers concerning illness and approaching death. | Cf. Traditional Jewish prayer times — In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this reference would remind the sick person and caregivers of the importance of maintaining regular prayer even during illness, connecting the individual's suffering to the broader communal rhythm of Jewish devotional life.

[ii] Abbreviated as "וגומר" (etc.) indicating that the reader should recite the complete prayer that begins with these words, which would have been familiar to the intended users of this prayer manual.

[iii] This refers to the threefold repetition of "Heal me, O LORD" (רְפָאֵנִי יְיָ) mentioned earlier in the text, which is followed by additional verses forming a healing prayer.

[iv] The phrase "my Rock and my Redeemer" (צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי) comes from Psalm 19:15 and marks the conclusion of this standardized prayer sequence.

[v] Cf. Psalm 19:15 — This reference serves as a standard closing for prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, marking the endpoint of the liturgical section. The use of this verse invokes both divine protection (Rock) and redemption, themes particularly relevant for healing prayers.

[vi] This is the header for the sixth liturgical sequence in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer system for the sick and dying. The title 'Seder Vav' (Order 6) indicates this is the sixth in a series of eight prayer orders.

יתחיל אנא ה׳ הושיעה נא וגומר[i] ככתוב בסדר א׳[ii] אחר כך יאמר מזמור ס״ג או ס״ז או ע״א או ע״ד[iii] ואחר כך יתחיל וזאת התורה:[iv]

He shall begin with[1] "Please, O LORD, save us" etc., as written in the first order.[2] Afterward, he shall recite Psalm 63 or 67 or 71 or 74,[3] and then he shall begin "And this is the Torah."[4]

(תהלים סג) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד בִּהְיוֹתוֹ בְּמִדְבַּר יְהוּדָה: אֱלֹהִים אֵלִי אַתָּה אֲשַׁחֲרֶךָּ צָמְאָה לְךָ נַפְשִׁי כָּמַהּ לְךָ בְשָׂרִי בְּאֶרֶץ־צִיָּה וְעָיֵף בְּלִי־מָיִם: כֵּן בַּקֹּדֶשׁ חֲזִיתִךָ לִרְאוֹת עֻזֶּךָ וּכְבוֹדֶךָ: כִּי־טוֹב חַסְדְּךָ מֵחַיִּים שְׂפָתַי יְשַׁבְּחוּנָךְ: כֵּן אֲבָרֶכְךָ בְחַיָּי בְּשִׁמְךָ אֶשָּׂא כַפָּי: כְּמוֹ חֵלֶב וָדֶשֶׁן תִּשְׂבַּע נַפְשִׁי וְשִׂפְתֵי רְנָנוֹת יְהַלֶּל־פִּי: אִם־זְכַרְתִּיךָ עַל־יְצוּעָי בְּאַשְׁמֻרוֹת אֶהְגֶּה־בָּךְ: כִּי־הָיִיתָ עֶזְרָתָה לִּי וּבְצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ אֲרַנֵּן:

A psalm of David, when he was in the wilderness of Judah. O God, You are my God, I seek You earnestly;[A] my soul thirsts for You, my flesh longs for You, in a dry and weary land without water.[B] So I have beheld You in the sanctuary,[5] to see Your power and Your glory. For Your loving-kindness is better than life; my lips shall praise You. So I will bless You as long as I live; in Your name I will lift up my hands. My soul shall be satisfied as with marrow and fatness, and my mouth shall praise You with joyful lips. When I remember You upon my bed, I meditate on You in the night watches. For You 1195R 1200R 1205R

[A] Or: "I seek You at dawn" — The Hebrew word 'אֲשַׁחֲרֶךָּ' comes from the root 'שחר' which relates to dawn or early morning. In context it refers to earnest seeking, but it can also specifically connote seeking God in the early morning hours, which would be relevant in the context of prayer cycles in Ma'avar Yabok.

[B] Or: "in a parched and exhausted land without water" — This more visceral translation of the Hebrew 'צִיָּה וְעָיֵף' emphasizes the physical depletion that parallels the spiritual thirst described in the psalm, which might better convey the metaphorical connection to the condition of illness in Ma'avar Yabok's context.

[1] The Hebrew verb "יתחיל" (yatchil) is in the third-person masculine singular form, creating an impersonal instruction typical of liturgical manuals. I've maintained this formal tone in the translation.

[2] This refers to the previously detailed prayer sequence (Seder Alef) where the complete opening formula was provided. Ma'avar Yabok uses this cross-referencing system throughout to create a practical manual that balances completeness with efficiency.

[3] The text offers a choice between these four psalms, likely because they contain themes appropriate for various situations related to illness or approaching death. This flexibility within structured prayer sequences is characteristic of Ma'avar Yabok.

[4] This phrase (וזאת התורה) comes from Deuteronomy 4:44 and traditionally begins a liturgical sequence recited when the Torah scroll is raised in synagogue. Here it appears to mark the beginning of a new section in this prayer sequence.

[5] The Hebrew 'כֵּן בַּקֹּדֶשׁ חֲזִיתִךָ' can be understood in multiple ways: as referring to past experiences of divine presence in the sanctuary that sustain the psalmist in the desert, or as expressing a wish to see God in the sanctuary as intensely as the current longing in the wilderness.

[i] This is a standard liturgical formula used throughout Ma'avar Yabok as the opening for each prayer sequence. The phrase "וגומר" (etc.) indicates that the full prayer should be recited as previously detailed in the text.

[ii] This refers back to the first prayer order (Seder Alef) where the complete opening formula was written out in full. This cross-referencing technique was common in prayer manuals to save space while ensuring proper recitation.

[iii] These are Hebrew numerical abbreviations for Psalms 63, 67, 71, or 74. The Hebrew letters used as numerals are: ס (samekh) = 60, ג (gimel) = 3, ז (zayin) = 7, ע (ayin) = 70, א (alef) = 1, ד (dalet) = 4.

[iv] "And this is the Torah"—these words begin a standard prayer recited when the Torah is raised in the synagogue, based on Deuteronomy 4:44. In this context, it appears to be the beginning of a specific prayer sequence or biblical verse collection that follows the psalm recitation.

דָּבְקָה נַפְשִׁי אַחֲרֶיךָ בִּי תָמְכָה
1120 יְמִינֶךָ: וְהֵמָּה לְשׁוֹאָה יְבַקְשׁוּ נַפְשִׁי
יָבֹאוּ בְּתַחְתִּיּוֹת הָאָרֶץ: יַגִּירֻהוּ
עַל־יְדֵי־חָרֶב מְנָת שֻׁעָלִים יִהְיוּ:
וְהַמֶּלֶךְ יִשְׂמַח בֵּאלֹהִים יִתְהַלֵּל
כָּל־הַנִּשְׁבָּע בּוֹ כִּי יָסָכֶר פִּי
1125 [i] דוֹבְרֵי־שָׁקֶר:

have been my help, and in the shadow of Your wings I sing for joy.[A] My soul clings to You; Your right hand upholds me. But those who seek to destroy my soul shall go into the depths of the earth.[1] They shall 1210R
be delivered to the power of the sword; they shall be a portion for jackals. But the king shall rejoice in God; everyone who swears by Him shall glory, for the mouth of those who speak lies shall be stopped.

(תהלים סז) לַמְנַצֵּחַ [ii] בִּנְגִינֹת מִזְמוֹר
שִׁיר: אֱלֹהִים יְחָנֵּנוּ וִיבָרְכֵנוּ יָאֵר
פָּנָיו אִתָּנוּ [iii] סֶלָה [iv]: לָדַעַת בָּאָרֶץ
דַּרְכֶּךָ בְּכָל־גּוֹיִם יְשׁוּעָתֶךָ [v]:
1130 יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים אֱלֹהִים יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים
כֻּלָּם: יִשְׂמְחוּ וִירַנְּנוּ לְאֻמִּים

(Psalm 67) For the Chief Musician, on stringed instruments.[2] A Psalm, a song. May God be gracious 1215R
to us and bless us; may He make His face shine upon us.[3] Selah. That Your way may be known on earth, Your salvation among all nations.[4] Let the peoples praise You, O God; let all the peoples praise You. Let 1220R

[A] Or: "and under the shelter of Your wings I rejoice" — The phrase 'under the shadow/shelter of Your wings' (בְּצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ) appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok as a key metaphor for divine protection, particularly for the vulnerable soul during illness and at the moment of death. This translation emphasizes the protective aspect of the metaphor.

[1] The phrase 'תַּחְתִּיּוֹת הָאָרֶץ' (depths of the earth) was traditionally understood as referring to Sheol, the abode of the dead. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would connect to discussions of the soul's journey after death and divine judgment of the wicked.

[2] The Hebrew term 'binginot' specifically refers to instrumental accompaniment, suggesting that this psalm was meant to be performed with musical instruments rather than merely recited. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this musical dimension might have been understood as having therapeutic properties for the sick.

[3] This phrase echoes the Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26) and carries profound theological significance. In kabbalistic thought, the 'shining face' of God represents divine favor, illumination, and healing power flowing from higher spiritual realms to the lower world.

[4] The psalm moves immediately from personal blessing to universal salvation, reflecting a pattern in Jewish thought where individual healing is connected to the broader divine plan for all humanity. This universalist perspective would be particularly meaningful for someone facing mortality.

[i] Cf. Psalm 42 — Psalm 42's 'As the deer pants for water brooks, so my soul pants for You, O God' parallels the imagery of thirsting for God in Psalm 63. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses would serve as powerful meditation prompts for the ill person to redirect their physical suffering toward spiritual longing for divine presence. | Cf. Zohar — The Zohar interprets 'in the shadow of Your wings I sing for joy' as referring to divine protection during prayer, particularly at critical moments. In Ma'avar Yabok, this phrase becomes a central metaphor for the protection of the soul during illness and at death, connecting personal prayer with cosmic processes of divine unification. | Cf. Genesis 32 — The phrase 'my soul clings to You' echoes Jacob's statement 'I will not let You go unless You bless me' during his wrestling at the Jabbok River. This connection is especially significant in Ma'avar Yabok, whose title directly references this biblical narrative as a metaphor for the soul's transition from life to death.

[ii] This musical instruction indicates the psalm was intended to be performed with stringed instruments. Its inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences suggests the therapeutic power of music was recognized alongside the words themselves in healing contexts.

[iii] The imagery of God's 'shining face' is central to Jewish blessing formulas and has particular significance in kabbalistic thought, where divine light is understood as a healing force that can penetrate the darkness of illness and suffering.

[iv] This musical notation appears twice in this short psalm, potentially indicating pauses for reflection or musical interludes. In the context of prayers for healing, these pauses might serve as moments for contemplation or for the sick person to rest.

[v] This verse connects personal blessing with universal divine revelation, suggesting that even in individual suffering, there is a larger purpose of making God's ways known to all people.

כִּי־תִשְׁפֹּט עַמִּים מִישֹׁר וּלְאֻמִּים
בָּאָרֶץ תַּנְחֵם סֶלָה: יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים
אֱלֹהִים יוֹדוּךָ עַמִּים כֻּלָּם: אֶרֶץ
נָתְנָה יְבוּלָהּ[i] יְבָרְכֵנוּ אֱלֹהִים
אֱלֹהֵינוּ:[ii]

the nations be glad and sing for joy,[A] for You judge the peoples with equity[1] and guide the nations upon earth. Selah. Let the peoples praise You, O God; let all the peoples praise You. The earth has yielded its produce;[B] may God, our God, bless us.

(תהלים עא) בְּךָ־יְיָ חָסִיתִי
אַל־אֵבוֹשָׁה לְעוֹלָם: בְּצִדְקָתְךָ
תַּצִּילֵנִי וּתְפַלְּטֵנִי הַטֵּה־אֵלַי אָזְנְךָ
וְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי: הֱיֵה לִי לְצוּר מָעוֹן
לָבוֹא תָּמִיד צִוִּיתָ לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי
כִּי־סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי אָתָּה: אֱלֹהַי
פַּלְּטֵנִי מִיַּד רָשָׁע מִכַּף מְעַוֵּל
וְחוֹמֵץ: כִּי־אַתָּה תִקְוָתִי אֲדֹנָי
יֱהוִה מִבְטַחִי מִנְּעוּרָי: עָלֶיךָ
נִסְמַכְתִּי מִבֶּטֶן מִמְּעֵי אִמִּי אַתָּה
גּוֹזִי בְּךָ תְהִלָּתִי תָּמִיד: כְּמוֹפֵת

In You, O LORD, I have taken refuge; let me never be put to shame. In Your righteousness, deliver me and rescue me; incline Your ear to me and save me. Be to me a rock of habitation to which I may continually come; You have given the commandment to save me, for You are my rock and my fortress. My God, deliver me from the hand of the wicked, from the grasp of the wrongdoer and the oppressor. For You are my hope, O Lord GOD, my confidence from my youth. Upon You I have leaned from birth;[C] from my mother's womb You have been my protector.[D][2] In

[A] Or: "Let the peoples rejoice and sing joyfully" — The Hebrew term 'le'umim' can be translated as either 'nations' or 'peoples.' While 'nations' is standard in many translations, 'peoples' might better preserve the parallelism with 'amim' (peoples) in the surrounding verses. Both translations are valid depending on whether one emphasizes political entities or human communities.

[B] Or: "The land has given its harvest" — The Hebrew 'eretz' can mean either 'earth' (globally) or 'land' (more locally), and 'yevulah' can refer to produce, harvest, or increase. This alternative emphasizes the agricultural aspect more directly, which might be more intuitive to modern readers unfamiliar with biblical idioms.

[C] Or: "Upon You I have been supported from the womb" — The Hebrew 'נִסְמַכְתִּי' (nismachti) has a connotation of being supported or upheld rather than simply leaning. The term 'מִבֶּטֶן' (mi-beten) specifically refers to 'from the womb' which is more precise than the general term 'birth'.

[D] Or: "You are my deliverer" — The term 'גּוֹזִי' (gozi) is somewhat rare and has connotations of cutting or severing (possibly from the cord at birth), and in this context implies one who delivers or extracts. 'Deliverer' captures this nuance better than 'protector,' though both convey aspects of the meaning.

[1] The Hebrew term 'mishor' (equity/uprightness) carries connotations of both justice and straightforwardness. In the context of prayers for the sick, this suggests confidence in divine fairness even amid suffering that might seem arbitrary or unjust.

[2] The Hebrew term 'גּוֹזִי' (gozi) is somewhat rare and may derive from a root meaning 'to cut' or 'to shear,' possibly referring to cutting the umbilical cord. This creates a powerful image of God as the one who has delivered the psalmist into life from the very beginning, establishing a lifelong relationship that continues into old age and illness.

[i] The agricultural metaphor of the earth yielding its produce appears in a psalm about divine blessing. In the context of illness and healing prayers, this might suggest that the 'fruit' of suffering could be spiritual growth or that recovery is like the earth's natural process of producing new life.

[ii] Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — This psalm incorporates language from the Priestly Blessing, which would have been immediately recognizable to Jewish readers. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this connection suggests that the psalm serves as a kind of priestly blessing for the sick or dying person, invoking divine light and grace during their time of need. | Cf. Zohar — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the phrase 'make His face shine upon us' would be understood as invoking the divine light that has healing and restorative properties according to kabbalistic tradition. The psalm's inclusion in a healing sequence suggests it was selected specifically for this mystical dimension. | Cf. Psalms 117 — Both psalms emphasize universal praise of God by all peoples and nations, suggesting that even in illness or approaching death, the individual participates in a cosmic chorus of praise that extends beyond Israel to all humanity.

הָיִיתִי לָרַבִּים וְאַתָּה מַחְסִי־עֹז׃
יִמָּלֵא פִי תְהִלָּתֶךָ כָּל־הַיּוֹם
תִּפְאַרְתֶּךָ׃ אַל־תַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי לְעֵת
זִקְנָה כִּכְלוֹת כֹּחִי אַל־תַּעַזְבֵנִי׃
כִּי־אָמְרוּ אוֹיְבַי לִי וְשֹׁמְרֵי נַפְשִׁי
נוֹעֲצוּ יַחְדָּו׃ לֵאמֹר אֱלֹהִים עֲזָבוֹ
רִדְפוּ וְתִפְשׂוּהוּ כִּי־אֵין מַצִּיל׃
אֱלֹהִים אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי אֱלֹהַי
לְעֶזְרָתִי (חישה) [חוּשָׁה]׃ יֵבֹשׁוּ
יִכְלוּ שֹׂטְנֵי נַפְשִׁי יַעֲטוּ חֶרְפָּה
וּכְלִמָּה מְבַקְשֵׁי רָעָתִי׃ וַאֲנִי תָמִיד
אֲיַחֵל וְהוֹסַפְתִּי עַל־כָּל־תְּהִלָּתֶךָ׃
פִּי יְסַפֵּר צִדְקָתֶךָ כָּל־הַיּוֹם
תְּשׁוּעָתֶךָ כִּי לֹא יָדַעְתִּי סְפֹרוֹת׃
אָבוֹא בִּגְבֻרוֹת אֲדֹנָי יֱהוִה
אַזְכִּיר צִדְקָתְךָ לְבַדֶּךָ׃ אֱלֹהִים
לִמַּדְתַּנִי מִנְּעוּרָי וְעַד־הֵנָּה אַגִּיד
נִפְלְאוֹתֶיךָ׃ וְגַם עַד־זִקְנָה וְשֵׂיבָה
אֱלֹהִים אַל־תַּעַזְבֵנִי עַד־אַגִּיד
זְרוֹעֲךָ לְדוֹר לְכָל־יָבוֹא גְּבוּרָתֶךָ׃
וְצִדְקָתְךָ אֱלֹהִים עַד־מָרוֹם
אֲשֶׁר־עָשִׂיתָ גְּדֹלוֹת אֱלֹהִים מִי
כָמוֹךָ׃ אֲשֶׁר (הראיתנו) [הֶרְאִיתַנִי]
צָרוֹת רַבּוֹת וְרָעוֹת תָּשׁוּב
[ ] (תחינו) [תְּחַיֵּנִי] וּמִתְּהֹמוֹת הָאָרֶץ
תָּשׁוּב תַּעֲלֵנִי׃ תֶּרֶב גְּדֻלָּתִי וְתִסֹּב
תְּנַחֲמֵנִי׃ גַּם־אֲנִי אוֹדְךָ בִכְלֵי־נֵבֶל
אֲמִתְּךָ אֱלֹהָי אֲזַמְּרָה לְךָ בְכִנּוֹר
קְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל׃ תְּרַנַּנָּה שְׂפָתַי כִּי
אֲזַמְּרָה־לָּךְ וְנַפְשִׁי אֲשֶׁר פָּדִיתָ׃

You is my praise continually. I have been as a wonder to many,[A] but You are my strong refuge. My mouth shall be filled with Your praise, with Your glory all day long. Do not cast me off in the time of old age;[1] when my strength fails, do not forsake me. For my enemies speak against me, and those who watch for my life take counsel together, saying, "God has forsaken him; pursue and seize him, for there is none to deliver." O God, do not be far from me; my God, hasten to my help. May those who are adversaries of my soul be ashamed and consumed; may those who seek my hurt be covered with reproach and dishonor. But as for me, I will hope continually, and will praise You yet more and more. My mouth shall tell of Your righteousness, of Your salvation all day long, though I know not how to recount them all.[B] I will come with the mighty deeds of the Lord GOD;[C] I will make mention of Your righteousness, Yours alone. O God, You have taught me from my youth, and until now I declare Your wondrous works. Even to old age and gray hairs, O God, do not forsake me, until I proclaim Your strength to this generation, Your might to everyone who is to come. Your righteousness, O God, reaches to the heights; You who have done great things, O God, who is like You? You who have shown me many troubles and distresses will revive me again; and from the depths of the earth You will bring me up again.[2] You will increase my greatness and turn to comfort me. I will also praise You with the harp for Your faithfulness, O my God; I will sing praises

1150 1155 1160 1165 1170 1175

1240R 1245R 1250R 1255R 1260R 1265R

[A] Or: "I have become like a portent to many" — The Hebrew 'מוֹפֵת' (mofet) often refers to a sign, portent, or omen rather than merely something that causes wonder. In this context, it suggests the psalmist's suffering has made him an example or sign that others observe with astonishment or as a warning.

[B] Or: "My mouth shall recount Your righteousness and Your salvation all day long, for I do not know their measure" — The phrase 'לֹא יָדַעְתִּי סְפֹרוֹת' (lo yadati seforot) literally means 'I do not know numbers/counting' and implies that the acts of salvation are beyond enumeration. 'I do not know their measure' captures this sense of immeasurability rather than suggesting inability to recount.

[C] Or: "I will enter into the mighty acts of the Lord GOD" — The Hebrew 'אָבוֹא' (avo) literally means 'I will enter/come into' rather than 'come with,' and 'בִּגְבֻרוֹת' (bigvurot) refers to mighty acts or powers. The alternate translation better conveys the sense of the psalmist immersing himself in or proclaiming God's mighty acts.

[1] This prayer against abandonment in old age would be particularly poignant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of caring for the elderly and dying. It reflects the common human fear of being forgotten or abandoned when weakened by age or illness, while expressing confidence that God's care extends throughout the entire lifespan.

[2] This verse expresses confidence in divine restoration, whether from the depths of illness or even from death itself. In Jewish mystical thought, 'the depths of the earth' (תְּהֹמוֹת הָאָרֶץ) can represent both physical death and spiritual descent, with the promise of elevation representing both healing and resurrection.

גַּם־לְשׁוֹנִי כָּל־הַיּוֹם תֶּהְגֶּה צִדְקָתֶךָ
כִּי־בֹשׁוּ כִּי־חָפְרוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי רָעָתִי׃ [i]

to You with the lyre, O Holy One of Israel. My lips will shout for joy when I sing praises to You, and my soul, which You have redeemed.[1] My tongue also will utter Your righteousness all day long, for they 1270R are ashamed, for they are humiliated who seek my hurt.

(תהלים עד) מַשְׂכִּיל לְאָסָף[ii] לָמָה
אֱלֹהִים זָנַחְתָּ לָנֶצַח יֶעְשַׁן אַפְּךָ
בְּצֹאן מַרְעִיתֶךָ׃ זְכֹר עֲדָתְךָ
קָנִיתָ קֶדֶם גָּאַלְתָּ שֵׁבֶט נַחֲלָתֶךָ
הַר־צִיּוֹן זֶה שָׁכַנְתָּ בּוֹ׃ הָרִימָה
פְעָמֶיךָ לְמַשֹּׁאוֹת נֶצַח כָּל־הֵרַע
אוֹיֵב בַּקֹּדֶשׁ׃ שָׁאֲגוּ צוֹרְרֶיךָ בְּקֶרֶב
מוֹעֲדֶךָ שָׂמוּ אוֹתֹתָם אֹתוֹת׃
יִוָּדַע כְּמֵבִיא לְמָעְלָה בְּסִבְכֵי־עֵץ
קַרְדֻּמוֹת׃ (ועת) [וְעַתָּה] פִּתּוּחֶיהָ
יָחַד בְּבַשִּׁיל וְכִילַפּוֹת יַהֲלֹמוּן׃
שִׁלְחוּ בָאֵשׁ מִקְדָּשֶׁךָ לָאָרֶץ חִלְּלוּ

(Psalm 74) A contemplative psalm of Asaph.[A] Why, O God, have You rejected us forever? Why does Your anger smoke against the sheep of Your pasture? 1275R Remember Your congregation which You purchased of old, which You redeemed as the tribe of Your inheritance, and Mount Zion, where You have dwelled. Lift up Your steps to the perpetual ruins;[B] the enemy has damaged everything in the sanctuary. Your 1280R adversaries have roared in the midst of Your meeting place;[2] they have set up their emblems as signs. They seemed like men who lifted up axes in a thicket of trees. And now all its carved work they break

[A] Or: "A maskil of Asaph" — The Hebrew term 'maskil' (מַשְׂכִּיל) is a musical or literary term whose precise meaning is uncertain. While 'contemplative psalm' is a good interpretive translation, retaining the technical term 'maskil' might be preferable in a scholarly context.

[B] Or: "to the everlasting desolations" — The Hebrew 'משואות' can refer to ruins or desolations, and 'נצח' can mean perpetual, everlasting, or complete. This alternate translation emphasizes the total destruction referenced in the psalm.

[1] The concept of the soul being 'redeemed' (פָּדִיתָ) carries significant weight in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework. It suggests not merely rescue from danger but spiritual liberation and restoration to divine connection, which aligns with the book's focus on proper spiritual preparation for death as the soul's ultimate redemption.

[2] The Hebrew term 'mo'adekha' refers to appointed meeting places, particularly the Temple or synagogues. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this could be understood metaphorically as the sacred space of prayer where the sick person encounters divine presence.

[i] Cf. Psalm 31 — The opening verses of Psalm 71 deliberately echo Psalm 31, establishing a connection between two prayers for deliverance. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this reinforces the practice of reciting familiar psalms during illness or at the approach of death, creating spiritual comfort through recognized patterns of prayer. | Cf. Psalm 22:9-10 — The reference to being supported by God from the womb echoes Psalm 22's similar imagery, creating a pattern of lifelong divine protection that would be particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context of end-of-life care. This reminds the ill person that the same God who has sustained them throughout life will continue to support them through death's transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — Verse 20 refers to being brought up from 'the depths of the earth' which parallels the central metaphor of Ma'avar Yabok—crossing over from one state to another. This psalm would thus serve as a particularly appropriate text for meditation during illness, reinforcing the book's theme that God who has sustained one throughout life will facilitate the crossing from life to death. | Cf. Zohar — The psalm's mention of 'my soul, which You have redeemed' (verse 23) would resonate with Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework concerning the soul's journey and redemption. In this context, the psalm serves not just as a prayer for physical healing but for the soul's proper elevation through the cosmic realms, a central concern of the book.

[ii] The term 'maskil' appears in the titles of 13 psalms. While traditionally translated as 'contemplative psalm' or 'instructive psalm,' its exact musical or liturgical meaning remains uncertain. In kabbalistic interpretation, it refers to a special type of contemplation that penetrates divine mysteries.

מִשְׁכַּן־שְׁמֶךָ: אָמְרוּ בִלְבָּם נִינָם
יָחַד שָׂרְפוּ כָל־מוֹעֲדֵי־אֵל בָּאָרֶץ:
אוֹתֹתֵינוּ לֹא רָאִינוּ אֵין־עוֹד
1195 נָבִיא וְלֹא־אִתָּנוּ יוֹדֵעַ עַד־מָה:
עַד־מָתַי אֱלֹהִים יְחָרֵף צָר יְנַאֵץ
אוֹיֵב שִׁמְךָ לָנֶצַח: לָמָּה תָשִׁיב יָדְךָ
וימינְךָ מִקֶּרֶב (חוקך) [חֵיקְךָ]
כַּלֵּה: וֵאלֹהִים מַלְכִּי מִקֶּדֶם פֹּעֵל
1200 יְשׁוּעוֹת בְּקֶרֶב הָאָרֶץ: אַתָּה
פוֹרַרְתָּ בְעָזְּךָ יָם שִׁבַּרְתָּ רָאשֵׁי
תַנִּינִים עַל־הַמָּיִם:[i] אַתָּה רִצַּצְתָּ
רָאשֵׁי לִוְיָתָן תִּתְּנֶנּוּ מַאֲכָל לְעָם
לְצִיִּים: אַתָּה בָקַעְתָּ מַעְיָן וָנָחַל
1205 אַתָּה הוֹבַשְׁתָּ נַהֲרוֹת אֵיתָן: לְךָ יוֹם
אַף־לְךָ לָיְלָה אַתָּה הֲכִינוֹתָ מָאוֹר
וָשָׁמֶשׁ: אַתָּה הִצַּבְתָּ כָּל־גְּבוּלוֹת
אָרֶץ קַיִץ וָחֹרֶף אַתָּה יְצַרְתָּם:
זְכָר־זֹאת אוֹיֵב חֵרֵף יְיָ וְעַם נָבָל
1210 נִאֲצוּ שִׁמֶךָ: אַל־תִּתֵּן לַחַיַּת נֶפֶשׁ
תּוֹרֶךָ[ii] חַיַּת עֲנִיֶּיךָ אַל־תִּשְׁכַּח
לָנֶצַח: הַבֵּט לַבְּרִית[iii] כִּי מָלְאוּ
מַחֲשַׁכֵּי־אֶרֶץ נְאוֹת חָמָס: אַל־יָשָׁב
דַּךְ נִכְלָם עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן יְהַלְלוּ
1215 שִׁמֶךָ: קוּמָה אֱלֹהִים רִיבָה רִיבֶךָ
זְכֹר חֶרְפָּתְךָ מִנִּי־נָבָל כָּל־הַיּוֹם:
אַל־תִּשְׁכַּח קוֹל צוֹרְרֶיךָ שְׁאוֹן

down with hatchet and hammers. They have set 1285R
Your sanctuary on fire; they have defiled the dwelling
place of Your name to the ground. They said in
their hearts, "Let us destroy them together."[A] They
have burned up all the meeting places of God in the
land. We do not see our signs; there is no longer any 1290R
prophet, nor is there anyone among us who knows
how long. How long, O God, will the adversary re-
vile? Will the enemy blaspheme Your name forever?
Why do You withdraw Your hand, even Your right
hand? Take it from Your bosom and destroy them. 1295R
Yet God is my King from of old, working salvation in
the midst of the earth. You divided the sea by Your
strength; You broke the heads of the sea monsters on
the waters. You crushed the heads of Leviathan; You
gave him as food for the people inhabiting the wilder- 1300R
ness. You split open spring and brook; You dried up
mighty rivers. The day is Yours, the night also is
Yours; You have prepared the light and the sun. You
have set all the boundaries of the earth;[1] You have
made summer and winter. Remember this, that the 1305R
enemy has reproached the LORD, and that a foolish
people has blasphemed Your name. Do not deliver
the soul of Your turtledove to the wild beast;[B2] do
not forget the life of Your poor forever. Look upon
the covenant;[3] for the dark places of the earth are 1310R

[A] Or: "Let us oppress them altogether" — The Hebrew is difficult here and there are textual variants. The verb could be derived from different roots meaning either 'destroy' or 'oppress/subdue.' The context supports either reading.

[B] Or: "the life of Your dove to the predator" — The term 'tor' (תּוֹר) refers to a turtledove or dove, often used metaphorically for Israel. 'Nefesh' can be translated as either 'soul' or 'life', while 'chayat' refers to a beast or predator. This alternate translation is more direct and maintains the metaphor.

[1] The psalm's emphasis on God's cosmic power over nature would be read in Ma'avar Yabok's context as reassurance that the one who established the fundamental laws of creation also has power over illness and death.

[2] This metaphor of Israel as God's vulnerable turtledove parallels how Ma'avar Yabok often portrays the sick person—as vulnerable and in need of divine protection. This imagery would resonate particularly in the context of prayers for the ill.

[3] This appeal to God's covenant serves as a model for how the sick should approach divine mercy—not based on personal merit but on the established relationship between God and Israel. Ma'avar Yabok frequently employs this covenant-based approach in its healing prayers.

[i] This references the ancient Near Eastern combat myth where a deity defeats sea monsters, representing chaos. In Jewish tradition, this was reinterpreted as God's victory over Egypt at the Red Sea crossing, symbolized as monstrous forces opposed to divine order.

[ii] The turtledove (tor) serves as a metaphor for Israel in Song of Songs and other biblical texts, representing vulnerability and beloved status. This metaphor would be significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of vulnerability during illness.

[iii] The appeal to covenant is a central motif in Jewish prayers for healing and protection. The psalmist reminds God of the binding agreement between them as grounds for divine intervention, a strategy also employed in traditional Jewish deathbed prayers.

קָמֶיךָ עֹלֶה תָמִיד: [i]

full of the habitations of violence.[A] Do not let the oppressed return ashamed; let the poor and needy praise Your name. Arise, O God, plead Your own cause; remember how the foolish man reproaches You daily. Do not forget the voice of Your adversaries; 1315R
the tumult of those who rise up against You ascends continually.

(תּוֹרָה) וְזֹאת הַתּוֹרָה[ii] אֲשֶׁר
1220 שָׂם מֹשֶׁה לִפְנֵי בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל:
שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְהוָה
אֶחָד:[iii] וְצְדָקָה תִּהְיֶה לָּנוּ כִּי
נִשְׁמֹר לַעֲשׂוֹת אֶת כָּל הַמִּצְוָה
הַזֹּאת לִפְנֵי יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר
1225 צִוָּנוּ: וְהִתְהַלַּכְתִּי בְּתוֹכְכֶם
וְהָיִיתִי לָכֶם לֵאלֹהִים וְאַתֶּם

And this is the Torah[1] which Moses set before the children of Israel. Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one.[2] And it shall be righteousness for us if we are careful to observe all this commandment before the LORD our God, as He has commanded us.[3] I will walk among you[B] and be your God, and you shall be My people. He will love you, bless you, and multiply you; He will also bless 1325R

[A] Or: "the dark places of the land are filled with haunts of violence" — The Hebrew 'eretz' can mean either 'earth' or 'land' (referring specifically to Israel), and 'ne'ot' refers to dwellings or haunts. This alternate translation is more concrete and may better capture the geographic specificity.

[B] Or: "I will move about in your midst" — This more literal rendering emphasizes God's immanent presence among the people, which in the context of Ma'avar Yabok would highlight divine attendance at the sickbed. This might be preferred in contexts focusing on God's intimate presence with the suffering.

[1] This opening serves to frame what follows as sacred text with divine authority. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses are presented as spiritual medicine with healing properties.

[2] The Shema is Judaism's central declaration of faith and is traditionally recited before death. Its inclusion here reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on maintaining focus on divine unity even during serious illness.

[3] This verse suggests that righteous observance of commandments contributes to healing, reflecting the book's view that proper spiritual conduct can influence physical wellbeing.

[i] Cf. Lamentations — This psalm shares the same historical context as Lamentations—the destruction of the Temple. The use of similar language and imagery would have been recognized by readers of Ma'avar Yabok as drawing upon the traditional Jewish literature of mourning and exile. | Cf. Zohar — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm would be understood through a kabbalistic lens where the destruction of the Temple represents not just a historical tragedy but a cosmic disruption in which divine presence itself is exiled. The imagery of God's 'right hand' being withdrawn relates to kabbalistic concepts of divine attributes being concealed. | Cf. Exodus narrative — The psalm deliberately contrasts God's past salvific actions with the present situation of apparent divine abandonment. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would serve as a model for how to approach personal tragedy—by remembering God's past interventions as grounds for hope amid current suffering. | Cf. Traditional Jewish prayers for the sick — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm's inclusion in a liturgical sequence for the sick teaches that personal illness can be understood through the lens of communal suffering and exile. The petitionary structure offers a model for how to approach God during times of physical distress, moving from lament to petition based on covenant relationship.

[ii] This phrase opens a new section in the sixth liturgical order (Seder Vav) of Ma'avar Yabok. By beginning with this declaration about the Torah, the text establishes the divine authority of the biblical verses that follow and frames them as part of sacred instruction that brings healing.

[iii] The Shema, Judaism's central declaration of monotheistic faith, holds special significance in the context of illness and approaching death. In Jewish tradition, it is recited as one's final words when possible, and in Ma'avar Yabok it serves to focus the ill person on divine unity.

תִּהְיוּ לִי לְעָם:[i] וַאֲהַבְךָ וּבֵרַכְךָ
וְהִרְבֶּךָ וּבֵרַךְ פְּרִי בִטְנְךָ וּפְרִי
אַדְמָתֶךָ דְּגָנְךָ וְתִירֹשְׁךָ וְיִצְהָרֶךָ
1230 שְׁגַר אֲלָפֶיךָ וְעַשְׁתְּרֹת צֹאנֶךָ עַל
הָאֲדָמָה אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע לַאֲבֹתֶיךָ לָתֵת
לָךְ: וְאָכַלְתָּ וְשָׂבָעְתָּ וּבֵרַכְתָּ[ii] אֶת
יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ עַל הָאָרֶץ הַטֹּבָה
אֲשֶׁר נָתַן לָךְ:[iii]

the fruit of your womb[A] and the fruit of your land, your grain, your wine, and your oil, the increase of your cattle and the offspring of your flock,[B] in the land that He swore to your fathers to give you. When you have eaten and are satisfied, you shall bless the 1330R LORD your God for the good land which He has given you.[1]

1235 (נביאים) וְעַתָּה יְהוָה אָבִינוּ
אָתָּה אֲנַחְנוּ הַחֹמֶר וְאַתָּה
יֹצְרֵנוּ[iv] וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדְךָ כֻּלָּנוּ: אַל תַּאַן
כָּמוֹךָ יְהוָה גָּדוֹל אַתָּה וְגָדוֹל שִׁמְךָ
בִּגְבוּרָה: יַסְּרֵנִי יְהוָה אַךְ בְּמִשְׁפָּט

And now, O LORD, You are our Father; we are the clay, and You are our potter,[2] and we are all the work of Your hand. There is none like You, O LORD; You 1335R are great, and Your name is great in might. Discipline me, O LORD, but with justice;[3] not in Your

[A] Or: "He will bless the offspring of your body" — This alternative avoids gender-specific language while maintaining the biblical concept. It might be preferred in contexts where gender-neutral language is prioritized.

[B] Or: "the calving of your herds and the lambing of your flocks" — This more specific translation captures the Hebrew terms that refer to the birthing or reproductive capacity of livestock. This might be preferred in contexts where the emphasis on fertility and reproduction is important to the interpretation.

[1] This final verse, which forms the basis for the Jewish grace after meals (Birkat Hamazon), reminds the ill person to maintain gratitude even in suffering. In Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, acknowledging divine goodness despite affliction is part of the healing process.

[2] This potter-clay metaphor establishes the relationship between God and humanity, serving as the theological foundation for the prayer's subsequent appeals. It acknowledges divine sovereignty while implicitly suggesting that suffering may be part of the divine shaping process.

[3] This petition acknowledges the appropriateness of divine correction while requesting moderation, perfectly aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's view of illness as potentially corrective rather than merely punitive. The supplicant accepts discipline but asks that it be measured.

[i] This covenant formula, "I will be your God and you will be My people," appears frequently in the Hebrew Bible and establishes the reciprocal relationship between God and Israel. In the context of illness, it serves as a reminder that even in suffering, the covenant relationship remains intact.

[ii] This verse forms the biblical basis for Birkat Hamazon, the Jewish grace after meals. Its inclusion in a healing sequence suggests that gratitude for divine provision should extend even through times of illness, with the hope of returning to normal activities like eating and blessing afterward.

[iii] Cf. Deuteronomy 4:44 — This opening verse establishes that the following text consists of sacred Torah passages, giving them authority as divine instruction for healing the sick. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4 — The inclusion of the Shema in this healing sequence is significant as it's traditionally recited before death. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, it serves to focus the ill person on divine unity during their suffering. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:25 — This verse suggests that healing may come through righteous observance of divine commandments, aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's view that illness can be a spiritual test. | Cf. Leviticus 26:12 — This divine promise of presence would be especially comforting to the ill, suggesting that God walks among them even in their suffering. | Cf. Deuteronomy 7:13-14 — These blessing verses serve as both a prayer for physical restoration and a reminder of God's covenant promises that extend to bodily wellbeing. | Cf. Deuteronomy 8:10 — This verse, the basis for the Jewish grace after meals, reminds the ill person to maintain gratitude even in suffering, acknowledging God's past and future provision.

[iv] The potter metaphor (God as potter, humans as clay) establishes a theological framework for understanding suffering: just as a potter shapes clay according to his design, God may use suffering to shape human lives. This biblical image was often invoked when seeking divine mercy during illness.

אַל בְּאַפְּךָ פֶּן תַּמְעִטֵנִי:[i] אִם עֲוֹנֵינוּ
עָנוּ בָנוּ יְהוָה עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ
כִּי רַבּוּ מְשׁוּבֹתֵינוּ לְךָ חָטָאנוּ:
מִקְוֵה יִשְׂרָאֵל[ii] מוֹשִׁיעוֹ בְּעֵת
צָרָה לָמָּה תִהְיֶה כְּגֵר בָּאָרֶץ
וּכְאֹרֵחַ נָטָה לָלוּן: לָמָּה תִהְיֶה
כְּאִישׁ נִדְהָם[iii] כְּגִבּוֹר לֹא יוּכַל
לְהוֹשִׁיעַ וְאַתָּה בְקִרְבֵּנוּ יְהוָה
וְשִׁמְךָ עָלֵינוּ נִקְרָא אַל תַּנִּחֵנוּ:
רְפָאֵנִי יְהוָה וְאֵרָפֵא הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי
וְאִוָּשֵׁעָה כִּי תְהִלָּתִי אָתָּה: אַל
תְּהִי לִי לְמַחְתָּה מַחְסִי־אַתָּה
בְּיוֹם רָעָה: יֵבֹשׁוּ רֹדְפַי וְאַל
אֵבֹשָׁה אֲנִי יֵחַתּוּ הֵמָּה וְאַל אֵחַתָּה,
אֲנִי הָבִיא עֲלֵיהֶם יוֹם רָעָה וּמִשְׁנֶה
שִׁבָּרוֹן שָׁבְרֵם:[iv] הַקְשִׁיבָה יְהוָה
אֵלַי וּשְׁמַע לְקוֹל יְרִיבָי: וַיהוָה
אוֹתִי כְּגִבּוֹר עָרִיץ[v] עַל כֵּן רוֹדְפַי
יִכָּשְׁלוּ וְלֹא יָכָלוּ בֹּשׁוּ מְאֹד כִּי לֹא
הִשְׂכִּילוּ כְּלִמַּת עוֹלָם לֹא תִשָּׁכַחַ:
כִּי אָנֹכִי יָדַעְתִּי אֶת הַמַּחֲשָׁבֹת
אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי חֹשֵׁב עֲלֵיכֶם נְאֻם יְהוָה
מַחְשְׁבוֹת שָׁלוֹם וְלֹא לְרָעָה לָתֵת
לָכֶם אַחֲרִית וְתִקְוָה:[vi]

anger, lest You diminish me. Though our iniquities testify against us, O LORD, act for Your name's sake; for our backslidings are many; we have sinned against You. O Hope of Israel, its Savior in time of trouble,[1] why should You be like a stranger in the land,[2] like a traveler who turns aside to lodge for a night? Why should You be like a man confused, like a mighty man who cannot save? Yet You, O LORD, are in our midst, and Your name is called upon us; do not leave us. Heal me, O LORD, and I shall be healed;[3] save me, and I shall be saved, for You are my praise. Do not be a terror to me; You are my refuge in the day of adversity. Let my persecutors be put to shame, but let me not be put to shame; let them be dismayed, but let me not be dismayed. Bring upon them the day of evil and destroy them with double destruction. Listen to me, O LORD, and hear the voice of my adversaries. But the LORD is with me as a dread warrior; therefore my persecutors will stumble; they will not overcome me. They will be greatly ashamed, for they will not succeed. Their eternal dishonor will never be forgotten. For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil,[4] to give

[1] This invocation combines two divine titles that would have particular resonance for the sick: God as both "Hope" (future possibility) and "Savior" (present deliverer). These titles establish expectation of divine response even when God seems distant.

[2] The imagery of God as a disinterested traveler expresses the profound sense of divine absence often experienced during serious illness. The prayer boldly gives voice to the sick person's feelings of abandonment while still maintaining the dialogue with God.

[3] This direct appeal from Jeremiah 17:14 becomes the central petition of this prayer sequence. The parallel structure (heal/healed, save/saved) emphasizes complete dependence on divine action, with human healing following as a natural consequence of divine intervention.

[4] The prayer concludes with divine reassurance from Jeremiah 29:11, shifting from human petition

[i] The Hebrew term תַּמְעִטֵנִי (diminish me) can mean to reduce in number or size, but in this context refers to being brought to nothing or utterly destroyed. The prayer acknowledges the legitimacy of divine discipline while asking that it be measured rather than overwhelming.

[ii] The term מִקְוֵה (mikveh) has a double meaning in Hebrew: "hope" and also "ritual bath." While primarily meaning "hope" here, the water imagery resonates with the concept of purification through suffering that appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[iii] The Hebrew נִדְהָם (confused/astonished) portrays God as seemingly inactive or bewildered, a bold anthropomorphism expressing the supplicant's sense of divine absence during illness. This reflects the existential struggle of the sick person who feels God's absence despite theological affirmation of divine presence.

[iv] The phrase "double destruction" (literally "double breaking") reflects the biblical principle of dual retribution found in passages like Jeremiah 16:18 and Isaiah 40:2. In the context of healing prayers, this might metaphorically represent the elimination of both physical illness and its spiritual causes.

[v] The phrase כְּגִבּוֹר עָרִיץ (as a dread warrior) presents God as a fearsome warrior fighting on behalf of the supplicant. This martial imagery contrasts with the earlier portrayal of God as seemingly inactive, showing the prayer's progression from doubt to confidence.

[vi] Cf. Isaiah 64:8 — This reference establishes the relationship between God and humans as creator and creation, which serves as a foundation for the subsequent appeals for mercy in this prayer sequence. | Cf. Jeremiah 10:6-7 — This reference establishes God's supreme power and

you a future and a hope.

(כתובים) אֱלֹהִים שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי
הַאֲזִינָה לְאִמְרֵי פִי: הִנֵּה
אֱלֹהִים עוֹזֵר לִי אֲדֹנָי בְּסוֹמְכֵי
נַפְשִׁי: [i] הָאֲזִינָה אֱלֹהִים תְּפִלָּתִי
וְאַל תִּתְעַלַּם מֵתַחֲנָתִי: [ii] עֲנֵנִי יְהוָה
כִּי טוֹב חַסְדֶּךָ כְּרֹב רַחֲמֶיךָ פְּנֵה
אֵלָי: וְאַל תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מֵעַבְדֶּךָ
כִּי צַר לִי מַהֵר עֲנֵנִי: אֶל נַפְשִׁי
גְּאָלָהּ לְמַעַן אוֹיְבַי פְּדֵנִי: וַאֲנִי עָנִי
וְכוֹאֵב יְשׁוּעָתְךָ אֱלֹהִים תְּשַׂגְּבֵנִי:
אֱלֹהִים לְהַצִּילֵנִי יְהוָה לְעֶזְרָתִי
חוּשָׁה: יֵבוֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי
נַפְשִׁי יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיִכָּלְמוּ רָעָתִי:
וַאֲנִי עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן אֱלֹהִים חוּשָׁה

O God, hear my prayer, listen to the words of my mouth. Behold, God helps me; the Lord is among those who sustain my soul.[A] Listen to my prayer, O God, and do not hide from my supplication. Answer me, O LORD, for Your loving-kindness is good; according to Your abundant compassion, turn to me. Do not hide Your face from Your servant, for I am in distress; answer me quickly. Redeem my soul; for the sake of my enemies, deliver me. I am poor and in pain; may Your salvation, O God, set me on high.[B] O God, to save me—O LORD, to help me—hasten! Let them be ashamed and confounded who seek my soul;[1] let them retreat backward and be humiliated who desire my harm. But I am poor and

1365R 1370R 1375R

[A] Or: "with the supporters of my soul" — This alternative translation emphasizes the human caregivers who might be present with the ill person, rather than placing God among them. This interpretation would be relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context where proper attendance of the sick is emphasized.

[B] Or: "Your salvation, O God, will protect me" — The verb 'תְּשַׂגְּבֵנִי' can connote protection rather than elevation. This alternate translation emphasizes divine protection during illness rather than exaltation, which might be more immediately relevant to the suffering person.

to God's perspective. This creates a therapeutic progression from distress through petition to confidence, exemplifying Ma'avar Yabok's approach of using prayer to transform the sick person's spiritual outlook from despair to hope.

[1] In the original context of Psalm 70, this referred to human enemies seeking one's life. In Ma'avar Yabok's context for the ill, it would be understood as referring to spiritual forces of illness or death that threaten the soul's wellbeing.

uniqueness, creating a theological foundation for the subsequent appeals for divine intervention and healing. | Cf. Jeremiah 10:24 — This reference aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that views illness as divine correction rather than mere punishment, acknowledging the need for discipline while requesting mercy. | Cf. Jeremiah 14:7-9 — These verses express both communal confession of sin and puzzlement at God's apparent distance, reflecting the book's approach to illness as potentially linked to sin while still expressing confidence in divine presence. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This direct appeal for healing is particularly appropriate in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the sick, expressing both need and confidence in divine healing power. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:17-18 — These verses shift from requesting personal protection to seeking judgment on adversaries, possibly representing in Ma'avar Yabok's context a prayer against both illness and negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Jeremiah 18:19 — This brief petition continues the theme of seeking divine intervention against opposition, which in the context of healing prayers might represent both human and spiritual adversaries. | Cf. Jeremiah 20:11 — This verse transforms the prayer from petition to confident assertion of divine presence and protection, exemplifying the pattern in Ma'avar Yabok's prayers of moving from distress to confidence. | Cf. Jeremiah 29:11 — This concluding verse shifts to God's perspective, offering reassurance of divine benevolence and future hope despite present suffering, perfectly aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's therapeutic approach to illness.

[i] This phrase can be interpreted in two ways: 'among those who sustain my soul' or 'with those who sustain my soul,' suggesting both divine companionship with human caregivers and divine presence among those helping the ill person.

[ii] The Hebrew contains a spelling irregularity in the word 'תִּתְעַלַּם' (hide yourself), which lacks the expected letter 'א'. This may be a scribal variation or intentional abbreviation common in prayer texts.

לִי עֶזְרִי וּמְפַלְטִי אַתָּה יְהוָה אַל
תְּאַחַר: מְגֹדָל עֹז שֵׁם יְהוָה בּוֹ יָרוּץ
1280 צַדִּיק וְנִשְׂגָּב: וְהָיָה שַׁדַּי בְּצָרֶיךָ
וְכֶסֶף תּוֹעָפוֹת לָךְ: יָחֹס עַל דַּל
וְאֶבְיוֹן וְנַפְשׁוֹת אֶבְיוֹנִים יוֹשִׁיעַ:
כַּפְּךָ מַעֲלֵי הַרְחֵק וְאֵימָתְךָ אַל
תְּבַעֲתַנִּי: שִׂימָה נָא עָרְבֵנִי עִמָּךְ מִי
1285 הוּא לְיָדִי יִתְקַע:[i] וְאֲנִי תָּמִיד עִמָּךְ
אָחַזְתָּ בְּיַד יְמִינִי: בַּעֲצָתְךָ תַּנְחֵנִי
וְאַחַר כָּבוֹד תִּקָּחֵנִי: וַאֲנִי קִרְבַת
אֱלֹהִים לִי טוֹב שַׁתִּי בַאדֹנָי יְהוָה
[ii] מַחֲסִי לְסַפֵּר כָּל מַלְאֲכוֹתֶיךָ:

needy; O God, hasten to me. You are my help and my deliverer; O LORD, do not delay. The name of the LORD is a tower of strength; the righteous runs into it and is safe. And the Almighty will be your protector, and you will have silver in abundance. He will have pity on the poor and needy, and the souls of the needy He will save. Remove Your hand from me, and let not Your dread terrify me. Please set me as Your guarantor;[A] who will strike hands with me? Yet I am always with You; You have grasped my right hand. With Your counsel You guide me, and afterward to glory You will take me. But as for me, the nearness of God is my good;[1] I have made the Lord GOD my refuge,[2] to tell of all Your works.

1290 ואח״כ יאמר למען יחלצון ידידיך [iii] וגו׳ רפאני ה׳

And afterward he shall say[B] "That Your beloved ones may be delivered, etc."[3] "Heal me, O LORD,

[A] Or: "Please give a pledge for me" — The Hebrew term can be understood as asking God to provide assurance rather than making the petitioner a guarantor. This interpretation makes more contextual sense in a prayer where the ill person is seeking divine intervention rather than offering to serve as surety.

[B] Or: "And then he shall recite" — The verb 'יאמר' can be translated as either 'say' or 'recite' in liturgical contexts. While 'say' is more literal, 'recite' might better convey the formal, ritual nature of the prayer instruction.

[1] This powerful line from Psalm 73:28 represents the culmination of the prayer's spiritual journey—from distress and supplication to intimate divine connection. It exemplifies Ma'avar Yabok's approach of guiding the ill person toward deeper spiritual awareness even amid suffering.

[2] This concluding section from Psalm 73 represents a spiritual transformation from the distressed supplications that began the prayer. The sequence models the journey Ma'avar Yabok hopes to facilitate for the ill—from desperate plea to confident trust.

[3] This is a standardized opening formula used throughout Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences, quoting the beginning of Psalm 60:7. The 'etc.' indicates that the complete verse would be recited, though not written out in full in the manual.

[i] This is an idiomatic expression from Job referring to a handshake that seals an agreement, literally 'who will strike hands with me.' In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it represents the ill person seeking divine assurance or covenant protection.

[ii] Cf. Psalms — This compilation follows a pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok, where selected verses from various psalms are combined to create a structured prayer for the sick and dying. The selection moves from pleas for divine attention to expressions of trust in divine salvation, modeling a therapeutic spiritual progression from distress to confidence. | Cf. Proverbs 18:10 — This verse is incorporated to emphasize divine protection in times of vulnerability, particularly relevant for the sick who seek refuge in God's power. In Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, divine names have special protective properties. | Cf. Job 22:25-27 — These verses from Job are repurposed in this healing prayer to provide comfort to the ill, suggesting that God will restore both spiritual and material wellbeing. | Cf. Job 13:21-22 — These verses from Job's dialogue with God are incorporated as expressions of the sick person's desire for relief from suffering, while seeking divine assurance.

[iii] This phrase comes from Psalm 60:7 and appears to be a standard opening formula for the concluding section of each prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok. The abbreviation 'וגו׳' indicates that the full verse would be familiar to users and doesn't need to be written out completely.

וגו׳[i] ככל הסדר הכתוב למעלה[ii] עד צורי וגואלי׳[iii iv] etc."[1] following the entire order written above[A] until "my Rock and my Redeemer."[2]

סדר ז[v] Order Seven 1395R

1295 יתחיל אנא ה׳ וגו׳ ככתוב לעיל[vi] ויאמר מזמור פה או פז או צא או קב[vii] ואח״כ יאמר Begin with "Please, O LORD..." etc. as written above,[B] and recite Psalm 85 or 87 or 91 or 102,[3] and afterward say "For Your salvation..."[4]

[A] Or: "according to the complete prayer sequence written above" — The term 'סדר' specifically refers to a liturgical sequence or arrangement in this context. This alternative translation makes the liturgical nature of the instruction more explicit.

[B] Or: "Begin by reciting "Please, O LORD..." etc. as previously written" — This alternative provides a slightly more explicit instruction about the recitation process. While both translations accurately convey the meaning, this version emphasizes the verbal action of recitation.

[1] This phrase from Jeremiah 17:14 is part of a standardized healing prayer that appears in multiple places throughout Ma'avar Yabok, typically with instructions to recite it three times.

[2] This phrase from Psalm 19:15 serves as the standard conclusion to each of the eight prayer sequences in the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok, creating a consistent liturgical framework while allowing variation in the specific psalms recited within each sequence.

[3] The flexibility to choose from four different psalms demonstrates Ma'avar Yabok's approach of providing options appropriate for various situations related to illness. Psalm 91 in particular was known as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions) and was considered especially powerful for protection against harmful forces.

[4] This refers to a prayer beginning with 'Lishu'atkha kiviti Hashem' (For Your salvation I hope, O LORD), which appears to be a standard transitional formula in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. This creates a structured progression from psalms to the biblical verse collections that typically follow.

[i] From Jeremiah 17:14, this healing verse is presented elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok with instructions to recite it three times, showing its importance in the prayer sequence for the sick.

[ii] This phrase indicates that the entire prayer sequence described earlier in the text should be recited. Ma'avar Yabok often uses such cross-references to avoid repeating lengthy prayer formulas.

[iii] From Psalm 19:15, this phrase serves as the standard conclusion to each prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok. The apostrophe after the word indicates the end of a section in the Hebrew manuscript.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 60:7 — This verse serves as a standard opening formula for the concluding section of each prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok, establishing the purpose of these prayers as seeking divine deliverance. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This verse is presented in Ma'avar Yabok as part of a standardized healing prayer sequence for the sick, with the instruction to recite it three times, emphasizing its importance in the healing liturgy. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — This verse serves as the standard conclusion to each of the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, creating a consistent liturgical framework. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section — This repeated instruction demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok creates standardized prayer structures for healing the sick, with consistent opening and closing formulas while allowing variation in the specific psalms and verses recited between them.

[v] The heading 'Seder Zayin' (Order 7) indicates this is the seventh of eight structured liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok designed for healing the sick and comforting the dying.

[vi] This is a liturgical instruction directing the reader to begin with the standard opening formula that starts with 'Ana Hashem' (Please, O LORD) which was provided in full earlier in the text. The abbreviation 'וגו׳" (etc.) indicates that the reader should recite the complete formula as previously given without needing to repeat it in full here.

[vii] This gives the reader options to recite one of four specific psalms: 85 (a psalm about divine forgiveness and restoration), 87 (about Zion as God's beloved city), 91 (known as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' or 'Song of Afflictions,' traditionally recited for protection), or 102 (a prayer of the afflicted). The choice likely depends on the specific circumstances of the sick person.

לישועתך:[i][ii]

(תהלים פה) לַמְנַצֵּחַ לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח
מִזְמוֹר: רָצִיתָ יְיָ אַרְצֶךָ שַׁבְתָּ
(שבות) [שְׁבִית][iii] יַעֲקֹב: נָשָׂאתָ
עֲוֹן עַמֶּךָ כִּסִּיתָ כָל־חַטָּאתָם
סֶלָה[iv]: אָסַפְתָּ כָל־עֶבְרָתֶךָ
הֱשֵׁבוֹתָ מֵחֲרוֹן אַפֶּךָ: שׁוּבֵנוּ
אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ וְהָפֵר כַּעַסְךָ עִמָּנוּ:
הַלְעוֹלָם תֶּאֱנַף־בָּנוּ תִּמְשֹׁךְ אַפְּךָ
לְדֹר וָדֹר: הֲלֹא־אַתָּה תָּשׁוּב תְּחַיֵּנוּ
וְעַמְּךָ יִשְׂמְחוּ־בָךְ: הַרְאֵנוּ יְיָ
חַסְדֶּךָ וְיֶשְׁעֲךָ תִּתֶּן־לָנוּ: אֶשְׁמְעָה
מַה־יְדַבֵּר הָאֵל יְיָ כִּי יְדַבֵּר שָׁלוֹם
אֶל־עַמּוֹ וְאֶל־חֲסִידָיו וְאַל־יָשׁוּבוּ
לְכִסְלָה: אַךְ קָרוֹב לִירֵאָיו יִשְׁעוֹ
לִשְׁכֹּן כָּבוֹד בְּאַרְצֵנוּ: חֶסֶד־וֶאֱמֶת
נִפְגָּשׁוּ צֶדֶק וְשָׁלוֹם נָשָׁקוּ[v]: אֱמֶת
מֵאֶרֶץ תִּצְמָח וְצֶדֶק מִשָּׁמַיִם נִשְׁקָף:

(Psalm 85) For the Chief Musician. A Psalm of the sons of Korah. You have favored, O LORD, Your land;[1] You have restored the captivity of Jacob.[A] You have forgiven the iniquity of Your people; You have covered all their sin. Selah. You have withdrawn all Your wrath; You have turned away from the heat of Your anger. Restore us, O God of our salvation, and annul Your anger with us. Will You be angry with us forever? Will You prolong Your anger from generation to generation? Will You not revive us again,[2] that Your people may rejoice in You? Show us, O LORD, Your loving kindness, and grant us Your salvation. I will hear what God the LORD will speak, for He will speak peace to His people and to His faithful ones, so that they do not return to folly.[B] Surely His salvation is near to those who fear Him, that glory

[A] Or: "You have returned the fortunes of Jacob" — The phrase could also be translated as 'returning the fortunes' rather than specifically referring to captivity. This alternate translation emphasizes restoration of prosperity rather than literal return from exile, which might be more appropriate in contexts focusing on healing and restoration rather than national redemption.

[B] Or: "let them not return to foolishness" — This alternative more directly captures the imperative tone of the Hebrew, emphasizing the warning against returning to foolishness after experiencing divine forgiveness and restoration, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual response to divine healing.

[1] The Hebrew verb רָצִיתָ literally means 'you have favored' or 'you have been pleased with,' suggesting divine approval returning to the land after a period of judgment.

[2] This verse is particularly significant in the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, as it directly petitions God for revival or restoration of life, making it especially appropriate for healing prayers.

[i] This indicates that after reciting the chosen psalm, one should say a prayer beginning with 'For Your salvation...' This appears to be a transitional formula used in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences, connecting psalm recitations to biblical verse collections that follow.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 91 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm would be understood as providing special spiritual protection for the sick or dying person against negative spiritual forces that might interfere with proper healing or the soul's peaceful transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's opening prayer formula — The book creates a consistent liturgical structure through repeated elements like this opening formula, allowing for variation in the psalm selections while maintaining a recognizable framework for those using the prayer manual.

[iii] The text contains a textual variant marked by parentheses and brackets. The word שבות (shevut) appears in parentheses, while the corrected or preferred reading שְׁבִית (shevit) appears in brackets. Both terms refer to captivity or exile, but the bracketed form is the standard Masoretic reading.

[iv] The term 'Selah' (סֶלָה) appears frequently in psalms and is traditionally understood as a musical or liturgical direction, possibly indicating a pause or musical interlude. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these musical notations would still be recited as part of the text when reading these psalms for the sick.

[v] This verse describes the meeting of divine attributes (loving kindness and truth, righteousness and peace), which in kabbalistic interpretation represents the balancing of different sefirot or divine emanations. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this harmony of divine attributes would be understood as the ideal spiritual state that creates healing and restoration.

גַּם־יְיָ יִתֵּן הַטּוֹב וְאַרְצֵנוּ תִּתֵּן
יְבוּלָהּ: צֶדֶק לְפָנָיו יְהַלֵּךְ וְיָשֶׂם
לְדֶרֶךְ פְּעָמָיו: [i]

may dwell in our land.[1] Loving kindness and truth have met together;[2] righteousness and peace have kissed each other.[3] Truth springs from the earth, and righteousness looks down from heaven. Indeed, the LORD will give what is good, and our land will yield its produce. Righteousness will go before Him and will set us on the way of His steps. 1420R

(תהלים פו) תְּפִלָּה לְדָוִד[ii] הַטֵּה־יְיָ
1320 אָזְנְךָ עֲנֵנִי כִּי־עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן אָנִי:
שָׁמְרָה נַפְשִׁי כִּי־חָסִיד אָנִי הוֹשַׁע
עַבְדְּךָ אַתָּה אֱלֹהַי הַבּוֹטֵחַ אֵלֶיךָ:
חָנֵּנִי אֲדֹנָי כִּי אֵלֶיךָ אֶקְרָא
כָּל־הַיּוֹם: שַׂמַּח נֶפֶשׁ עַבְדֶּךָ כִּי
1325 אֵלֶיךָ אֲדֹנָי נַפְשִׁי אֶשָּׂא: כִּי־אַתָּה
אֲדֹנָי טוֹב וְסַלָּח וְרַב־חֶסֶד
לְכָל־קֹרְאֶיךָ: הַאֲזִינָה יְיָ תְּפִלָּתִי
וְהַקְשִׁיבָה בְּקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנוֹתָי:
בְּיוֹם צָרָתִי אֶקְרָאֶךָּ כִּי תַעֲנֵנִי:
1330 אֵין־כָּמוֹךָ בָאֱלֹהִים אֲדֹנָי וְאֵין

(Psalm 86) A prayer of David. Incline Your ear, O LORD, answer me, for I am poor and needy. Guard my soul, for I am devoted;[A4] save Your servant, You, my God, who trusts in You. Be gracious to me, O Lord, for to You I call all day long. Gladden the soul of Your servant, for to You, O Lord, I lift up my soul. For You, O Lord, are good and forgiving, abundant in kindness to all who call upon You. Give ear, O LORD, to my prayer, and attend to the voice of my supplications. In the day of my distress I call upon You, for You will answer me. There is none like You among the gods, O Lord, and there are no works 1425R 1430R

[A] Or: "pious" — The Hebrew term 'chasid' can refer to one who is devoted, pious, faithful, or godly. In this context, it refers to someone who maintains faithful devotion to God, which could be rendered as 'pious' to emphasize the religious dimension of this devotion.

[1] The Hebrew word for 'glory' (כבוד/kavod) is frequently associated in kabbalistic texts with the divine presence. In the context of healing prayers, this would suggest the restoration of divine presence that brings healing.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, as reflected in Ma'avar Yabok, 'loving kindness' (חסד/chesed) and 'truth' (אמת/emet, often associated with judgment/din) represent different divine attributes or sefirot. Their meeting symbolizes the balancing of mercy and judgment that is particularly sought during illness.

[3] This poetic image of divine attributes kissing would be understood in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework as representing the perfect harmony of seemingly opposing divine qualities—judgment (righteousness) and mercy (peace)—that creates healing and restoration.

[4] The Hebrew term 'chasid' (translated here as 'devoted') carries connotations of piety, faithfulness, and loving devotion to God. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse would be understood as the ill person claiming a special relationship with God as the basis for divine protection.

[i] Cf. Psalm 85 — This psalm appears in the second liturgical order (Seder B) of Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine forgiveness, restoration, and renewal make it particularly appropriate for those seeking healing, as it creates a framework of hope that divine mercy will overcome judgment. | Cf. Job 33:19-30 — The reference to being 'revived again' in Psalm 85:7 resonates with Ma'avar Yabok's framing of illness as divine correction that can lead to restoration, similar to Elihu's speech in Job where he describes how God brings people to the edge of death but then restores them when they properly respond to divine discipline. | Cf. Zohar on Divine Attributes — The meeting of 'loving kindness and truth' and the kissing of 'righteousness and peace' in verses 11-12 represents the kabbalistic concept of balanced divine attributes that Ma'avar Yabok frequently references. This imagery of divine attributes in harmonious relationship would be interpreted in the book's kabbalistic framework as representing the ideal balance between judgment (truth/righteousness) and mercy (loving kindness/peace) that the sick person hopes to experience.

[ii] This superscription identifies the psalm as 'A prayer of David.' In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this attribution would have special significance as King David was considered an exemplary model for proper prayer, especially in times of distress.

כְּמַעֲשֶׂיךָ: כָּל־גּוֹיִם אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתָ
יָבוֹאוּ וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לְפָנֶיךָ אֲדֹנָי
וְיכַבְּדוּ לִשְׁמֶךָ: כִּי־גָדוֹל אַתָּה
וְעֹשֵׂה נִפְלָאוֹת אַתָּה אֱלֹהִים
לְבַדֶּךָ: הוֹרֵנִי יְיָ דַּרְכֶּךָ אֲהַלֵּךְ
בַּאֲמִתֶּךָ יַחֵד לְבָבִי לְיִרְאָה שְׁמֶךָ:
אוֹדְךָ אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהַי בְּכָל־לְבָבִי
וַאֲכַבְּדָה שִׁמְךָ לְעוֹלָם: כִּי־חַסְדְּךָ
גָּדוֹל עָלָי וְהִצַּלְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מִשְּׁאוֹל
תַּחְתִּיָּה[i]: אֱלֹהִים זֵדִים קָמוּ־עָלָי
וַעֲדַת עָרִיצִים בִּקְשׁוּ נַפְשִׁי
וְלֹא שָׂמוּךָ לְנֶגְדָּם: וְאַתָּה אֲדֹנָי
אֵל־רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם
וְרַב־חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת[ii]: פְּנֵה אֵלַי
וְחָנֵּנִי תְּנָה־עֻזְּךָ לְעַבְדֶּךָ וְהוֹשִׁיעָה
לְבֶן־אֲמָתֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה־עִמִּי אוֹת
לְטוֹבָה וְיִרְאוּ שֹׂנְאַי וְיֵבֹשׁוּ
כִּי־אַתָּה יְיָ עֲזַרְתַּנִי וְנִחַמְתָּנִי[iii]:

like Yours. All nations that You have made shall come and bow down before You, O Lord, and shall honor Your name. For You are great and perform wonders; You alone are God. Teach me Your way, O LORD, that I may walk in Your truth; unite my heart to fear Your name.[1] I will thank You, O Lord my God, with all my heart, and I will honor Your name forever. For Your kindness toward me is great, and You have delivered my soul from the depths of Sheol.[A] O God, the arrogant have risen against me, and a band of violent men have sought my life, and they have not set You before them. But You, O Lord, are a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abundant in kindness and truth. Turn to me and be gracious to me; grant Your strength to Your servant, and save the son of Your handmaid.[B] Show me a sign for good,[2] that my enemies may see and be ashamed, for You, LORD, have helped me and comforted me.

יֹשֵׁב (תהלים צא) בְּסֵתֶר עֶלְיוֹן
בְּצֵל שַׁדַּי יִתְלוֹנָן[iv]: אֹמַר לַיהוָה

(Psalm 91) He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty. I will

[A] Or: "from the nethermost pit" — The Hebrew phrase refers specifically to the lowest depths of Sheol (the underworld). This alternate translation emphasizes the spatial dimension of the deepest part of the underworld, which might be clearer for readers unfamiliar with the concept of Sheol.

[B] Or: "the child of Your maidservant" — This biblical expression refers to one born into service to God. The alternate translation uses gender-neutral language while preserving the meaning of one who belongs to God's household through maternal lineage.

[1] This phrase about unifying the heart would have special resonance in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, where spiritual fragmentation was considered a consequence of sin, and unification (yichud) of heart, mind, and soul was a primary spiritual goal, especially when facing death.

[2] In the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this request for a 'sign for good' would be interpreted as a plea for visible evidence of healing or divine favor that would both encourage the ill person and demonstrate God's power to onlookers.

[i] The term 'Sheol tachtiyah' (lowest Sheol) refers to the deepest part of the underworld in biblical cosmology. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would be interpreted as referring to both physical death and spiritual peril, making this psalm particularly appropriate for those facing serious illness.

[ii] This is a partial citation of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7), which held special significance in Jewish prayer traditions, particularly for seeking divine forgiveness and healing. The recitation of these divine attributes was considered especially powerful in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework.

[iii] Cf. Book of Psalms — This is a direct quotation of Psalm 86, which appears in the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine mercy, protection, and plea for salvation make it particularly appropriate in the context of illness and approaching death. | Cf. Traditional Jewish liturgy — This psalm is part of a structured prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok designed for healing the sick and comforting the dying. It appears in the fifth liturgical order (Seder Hei), as noted in the context. The inclusion of complete psalms in these sequences provides ready-made prayers for those attending the sick. | Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework would interpret the reference to 'lifting up my soul' (verse 4) as connecting to the mystical concept of elevating one's soul to higher spiritual realms during prayer, particularly relevant during illness when the soul's connection to the body is weakened.

[iv] The metaphor of divine protection under shadow or wings appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok as a key image of divine care for the vulnerable soul during illness and at the moment of death.

מַחְסִי וּמְצוּדָתִי אֱלֹהַי אֶבְטַח־בּוֹ׃
כִּי הוּא יַצִּילְךָ מִפַּח יָקוּשׁ
מִדֶּבֶר הַוּוֹת׃[i] בְּאֶבְרָתוֹ יָסֶךְ לָךְ
וְתַחַת־כְּנָפָיו תֶּחְסֶה צִנָּה וְסֹחֵרָה
1355 אֲמִתּוֹ׃[ii] לֹא־תִירָא מִפַּחַד לָיְלָה
מֵחֵץ יָעוּף יוֹמָם׃ מִדֶּבֶר בָּאֹפֶל
יְהַלֵּךְ מִקֶּטֶב יָשׁוּד צָהֳרָיִם׃[iii]
יִפֹּל מִצִּדְּךָ אֶלֶף וּרְבָבָה מִימִינֶךָ
אֵלֶיךָ לֹא יִגָּשׁ׃ רַק בְּעֵינֶיךָ תַבִּיט
1360 וְשִׁלֻּמַת רְשָׁעִים תִּרְאֶה׃ כִּי־אַתָּה
יְיָ מַחְסִי עֶלְיוֹן שַׂמְתָּ מְעוֹנֶךָ׃
לֹא־תְאֻנֶּה אֵלֶיךָ רָעָה וְנֶגַע
לֹא־יִקְרַב בְּאָהֳלֶךָ׃ כִּי מַלְאָכָיו
יְצַוֶּה־לָּךְ לִשְׁמָרְךָ בְּכָל־דְּרָכֶיךָ׃
1365 עַל־כַּפַּיִם יִשָּׂאוּנְךָ פֶּן־תִּגּוֹף בָּאֶבֶן
רַגְלֶךָ׃ עַל־שַׁחַל וָפֶתֶן תִּדְרֹךְ
תִּרְמֹס כְּפִיר וְתַנִּין׃ כִּי בִי חָשַׁק
וַאֲפַלְּטֵהוּ אֲשַׂגְּבֵהוּ כִּי־יָדַע שְׁמִי׃
יִקְרָאֵנִי וְאֶעֱנֵהוּ עִמּוֹ־אָנֹכִי בְצָרָה
1370 אֲחַלְּצֵהוּ וַאֲכַבְּדֵהוּ׃ אֹרֶךְ יָמִים
אַשְׂבִּיעֵהוּ וְאַרְאֵהוּ בִּישׁוּעָתִי׃[iv]

say to the LORD, "My refuge and my fortress, my 1455R
God, in whom I trust." For He shall save you from
the fowler's snare, from the destructive plague. He
will cover you with His pinions, and under His wings
you shall find refuge;[1] His truth shall be your shield
and buckler. You shall not fear the terror of night, 1460R
nor the arrow that flies by day. Nor the pestilence
that stalks in darkness, nor the destruction that rav-
ages at noon.[2] A thousand may fall at your side, and
ten thousand at your right hand, but it shall not ap-
proach you. You will only look with your eyes and see 1465R
the recompense of the wicked. For You, O LORD,
are my refuge; you have made the Most High your
dwelling place. No evil shall befall you, nor shall any
plague come near your tent. For He shall command
His angels concerning you, to guard you in all your 1470R
ways. They shall bear you up in their hands, lest
you strike your foot against a stone. You shall tread
upon the lion and the cobra; you shall trample the
young lion and the serpent. "Because he has set his
love upon Me, therefore I will deliver him; I will set 1475R
him on high, because he has known My name. He
shall call upon Me, and I will answer him; I will be
with him in trouble;[3] I will deliver him and honor

[1]This psalm was considered particularly powerful for protection during illness and at the moment of death. In the kabbalistic framework of Ma'avar Yabok, these divine 'wings' represent the sheltering presence of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) that protects the vulnerable soul.

[2]The Hebrew term 'ketev' refers to a specific destructive force or demon associated with midday in rabbinic literature. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm's enumeration of dangers at different times of day would be understood as comprehensive protection against all harmful spiritual forces that might threaten the ill or dying person.

[3]This divine promise of presence during trouble was particularly meaningful in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where it would be understood as God's companionship during the soul's difficult transition from life to death.

[i]The Hebrew term 'dever' (plague/pestilence) held particular resonance for readers in early modern Italy, who faced recurring plague epidemics. Ma'avar Yabok was published in 1626, shortly after major outbreaks in northern Italy.

[ii]The military imagery of shield and buckler would be understood in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic context as representing divine attributes that provide spiritual protection during the vulnerable moments of illness and death.

[iii]This verse refers to destruction at noon, which rabbinic tradition associated with specific demons active at midday. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, these references to harmful forces at different times of day reflect the belief that the dying were particularly vulnerable to negative spiritual entities.

[iv]Cf. Zohar — In Ma'avar Yabok's context, Psalm 91 is known as 'shir shel pega'im' (Song of Afflictions) and is recited for its protective properties, especially for the sick and dying. The Zohar identifies this psalm as having special power against harmful spiritual forces. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This psalm appears in the fifth liturgical order (Seder Hei) of Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine protection make it particularly appropriate in the context of illness and approaching death. | Cf. Talmud — The Talmud refers to Psalm 91 as 'shir shel pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons) and recommends its recitation for protection against harmful forces. In Ma'avar Yabok, this protective function is applied specifically to the context of illness and death.

him. With long life I will satisfy him, and show him My salvation."[1] 1480R

(תהלים קב) תְּפִלָּה לְעָנִי
כִּי־יַעֲטֹף וְלִפְנֵי יְיָ יִשְׁפֹּךְ שִׂיחוֹ:
יְיָ שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי וְשַׁוְעָתִי אֵלֶיךָ
1375 תָּבוֹא: אַל־תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי
בְּיוֹם צַר־לִי הַטֵּה־אֵלַי אָזְנֶךָ
בְּיוֹם אֶקְרָא מַהֵר עֲנֵנִי: כִּי־כָלוּ
בָעָשָׁן יָמָי וְעַצְמוֹתַי כְּמוֹקֵד נָחָרוּ:
הוּכָּה־כָעֵשֶׂב וַיִּבַשׁ לִבִּי כִּי־שָׁכַחְתִּי
1380 מֵאֲכֹל לַחְמִי: מִקּוֹל אַנְחָתִי דָּבְקָה
עַצְמִי לִבְשָׂרִי: דָּמִיתִי לְקָאַת
מִדְבָּר הָיִיתִי כְּכוֹס חָרָבוֹת:
שָׁקַדְתִּי וָאֱהִי כְּצִפּוֹר בּוֹדֵד
עַל־גָּג: כָּל־הַיּוֹם חֵרְפוּנִי אוֹיְבָי
1385 מְהוֹלָלַי בִּי נִשְׁבָּעוּ: כִּי־אֵפֶר
כַּלֶּחֶם אָכָלְתִּי וְשִׁקָּוַי בִּבְכִי
מָסָכְתִּי: [i]מִפְּנֵי־זַעְמְךָ וְקִצְפֶּךָ
כִּי נְשָׂאתַנִי וַתַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי: יָמַי כְּצֵל
נָטוּי וַאֲנִי כָּעֵשֶׂב אִיבָשׁ: וְאַתָּה יְיָ
1390 לְעוֹלָם תֵּשֵׁב וְזִכְרְךָ לְדֹר וָדֹר:
אַתָּה תָקוּם תְּרַחֵם צִיּוֹן כִּי־עֵת
לְחֶנְנָהּ כִּי־בָא מוֹעֵד: כִּי־רָצוּ
עֲבָדֶיךָ אֶת־אֲבָנֶיהָ וְאֶת־עֲפָרָהּ
יְחֹנֵנוּ: וְיִירְאוּ גוֹיִם אֶת־שֵׁם יְיָ
1395 וְכָל־מַלְכֵי הָאָרֶץ אֶת־כְּבוֹדֶךָ:

(Psalm 102) A prayer of the afflicted, when he is overwhelmed[2] and pours out his complaint before the LORD. O LORD, hear my prayer, and let my cry come to You. Do not hide Your face from me in the day of my distress; incline Your ear to me; on the 1485R day I call, answer me quickly. For my days vanish like smoke, and my bones burn like a hearth.[3] My heart is stricken and withered like grass, for I have forgotten to eat my bread. Because of the sound of my groaning, my bones cling to my flesh. I am like 1490R a pelican of the wilderness; I have become like an owl of the ruins.[A] I keep watch and have become like a solitary bird on a rooftop. All day my enemies taunt me; those who mock me use my name as a curse.[B] For I have eaten ashes like bread and mingled 1495R my drink with weeping, because of Your indignation and Your wrath, for You have lifted me up and cast me away. My days are like a lengthened shadow, and I wither away like grass. But You, O LORD, are enthroned forever, and Your remembrance is from 1500R generation to generation. You will arise and have mercy on Zion, for it is time to favor her; the appointed time has come. For Your servants take pleasure in her stones and show favor to her dust. The

[A] Or: "I resemble a desert owl; I have become like an owl among ruins" — The Hebrew 'קָאַת' (qa'at) is a bird whose exact identification is uncertain. While traditionally translated as 'pelican,' many modern scholars suggest it more likely refers to a type of owl or desert bird. This alternate translation reflects that scholarly consensus while maintaining the poetic parallel structure.

[B] Or: "those who rage against me swear by me" — The Hebrew 'מְהוֹלָלַי' (meholalai) can be understood either as 'those who mock/deride me' or 'those who are mad/rage against me.' The phrase 'בִּי נִשְׁבָּעוּ' literally means 'swear by me' and contextually suggests using the psalmist's name in oaths or curses. This alternate translation stays closer to the literal Hebrew while preserving the sense of being used as a negative example.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, 'salvation' (yeshuah) extends beyond physical healing to encompass the soul's successful journey after death—precisely the transition that the book's title 'Crossing of the Yabok' metaphorically represents.

[2] The Hebrew 'יַעֲטֹף' (ya'atof) literally means 'to be wrapped up' or 'to faint/grow feeble.' In the context of illness and approaching death, this refers to someone completely enveloped by suffering and weakness, which explains why this psalm was included in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences for the sick.

[3] This vivid physical description of wasting illness would have particular relevance for the dying person, comparing life's brevity to dissipating smoke and describing the burning fever sensation often experienced in serious illness. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would be understood as both literal suffering and a spiritual process of purification.

[i] This verse uses powerful imagery of consuming ashes and tears that would resonate with mourning practices. Ashes were traditionally associated with mourning in ancient Israel, while the mixing of tears with drink graphically depicts overwhelming grief.

כִּי־בָנָה יְיָ צִיּוֹן נִרְאָה בִּכְבוֹדוֹ׃
פָּנָה אֶל־תְּפִלַּת הָעַרְעָר וְלֹא־בָזָה
אֶת־תְּפִלָּתָם׃ תִּכָּתֵב זֹאת לְדוֹר
אַחֲרוֹן וְעַם נִבְרָא יְהַלֶּל־יָהּ׃
כִּי־הִשְׁקִיף מִמְּרוֹם קָדְשׁוֹ יְיָ
מִשָּׁמַיִם אֶל־אֶרֶץ הִבִּיט׃ לִשְׁמֹעַ
אֶנְקַת אָסִיר לְפַתֵּחַ בְּנֵי תְמוּתָה׃
לְסַפֵּר בְּצִיּוֹן שֵׁם יְיָ וּתְהִלָּתוֹ
בִּירוּשָׁלָם׃ בְּהִקָּבֵץ עַמִּים יַחְדָּו
וּמַמְלָכוֹת לַעֲבֹד אֶת־יְיָ׃[i] עִנָּה
בַדֶּרֶךְ (כחו) [כֹּחִי][ii] קִצַּר יָמָי׃
אֹמַר אֵלִי אַל־תַּעֲלֵנִי בַּחֲצִי יָמָי
בְּדוֹר דּוֹרִים שְׁנוֹתֶיךָ׃ לְפָנִים
הָאָרֶץ יָסַדְתָּ וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֶיךָ שָׁמָיִם׃
הֵמָּה יֹאבֵדוּ וְאַתָּה תַעֲמֹד וְכֻלָּם
כַּבֶּגֶד יִבְלוּ כַּלְבוּשׁ תַּחֲלִיפֵם
וְיַחֲלֹפוּ׃ וְאַתָּה־הוּא וּשְׁנוֹתֶיךָ לֹא
יִתַּמּוּ׃ בְּנֵי־עֲבָדֶיךָ יִשְׁכֹּונוּ וְזַרְעָם
לְפָנֶיךָ יִכּוֹן׃[iii]

nations will fear the name of the LORD, and all the kings of the earth Your glory. For the LORD has built up Zion; He has appeared in His glory. He has regarded the prayer of the destitute and has not despised their prayer.[A] This will be written for a generation to come, and a people yet to be created will praise the LORD. For He looked down from His holy height; from heaven the LORD gazed upon the earth, to hear the groaning of the prisoner, to release those condemned to death, to declare the name of the LORD in Zion and His praise in Jerusalem, when peoples and kingdoms gather together to serve the LORD.[1] He has weakened my strength in the way; He has shortened my days. I said, "O my God, do not take me away in the midst of my days; Your years are throughout all generations." Of old You laid the foundation of the earth, and the heavens are the work of Your hands. They will perish, but You will endure; indeed, all of them will wear out like a garment; like clothing You will change them, and they will pass away. But You are the same, and Your years will not end. The children of Your servants will dwell securely, and their offspring will be established before You.

[A] Or: "He has turned to the prayer of the stripped bare and has not disdained their supplication" — The Hebrew 'הָעַרְעָר' (ha'ar'ar) is relatively rare and refers to someone completely stripped of resources or utterly exposed. 'Destitute' captures the meaning, but 'stripped bare' might better convey the vivid image of complete vulnerability in the original. This provides a more evocative translation that could resonate with the sick or dying person for whom this psalm was intended.

[1] The psalm moves from intense personal suffering to universal cosmic hope, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's approach of placing individual death within a larger framework of ultimate redemption. This eschatological vision provides comfort by suggesting that present suffering is temporary within God's eternal plan.

[i] This verse expresses an eschatological hope for universal worship of God, where all nations gather together in divine service. This theme of ultimate redemption provides comfort in the context of present suffering.

[ii] The text shows a scribal correction. The original text had 'כחו' (his strength) but was corrected to 'כֹּחִי' (my strength), as indicated by the square brackets. This reflects the careful textual transmission practices in Hebrew manuscripts.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — Psalm 102 was specifically selected for inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences because of its themes of profound physical suffering, mortality awareness, and ultimate hope in divine mercy. These themes resonated with the book's purpose of providing spiritual comfort for the sick and dying. | Cf. Zohar — In the kabbalistic framework of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm's imagery of suffering followed by divine mercy would be interpreted as representing the transformation of judgment (din) to compassion (rachamim), which is a central theme in Jewish mystical approaches to illness and death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli — This talmudic interpretation would be particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as it provides reassurance that God hears the prayers of the ill and dying, which is a core theological message of the book's prayer sequences.

(תורה) לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְהוָה:
הוּא תְהִלָּתְךָ וְהוּא אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר
עָשָׂה אִתְּךָ אֶת הַגְּדֹלֹת וְאֶת
הַנּוֹרָאֹת הָאֵלֶּה אֲשֶׁר רָאוּ עֵינֶיךָ:
וְלֹא אָבָה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ לִשְׁמֹעַ אֶל
בִּלְעָם וַיַּהֲפֹךְ יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ לְךָ אֶת
הַקְּלָלָה לִבְרָכָה כִּי אֲהֵבְךָ יְהוָה
אֱלֹהֶיךָ: אֶת יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ תִּירָא
וְאֹתוֹ תַעֲבֹד וּבוֹ תִדְבָּק וּבִשְׁמוֹ
תִּשָּׁבֵעַ: כִּי שֵׁם יְהוָה אֶקְרָא הָבוּ
גֹדֶל לֵאלֹהֵינוּ: אַשְׁרֶיךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל מִי
כָמוֹךָ עַם נוֹשַׁע בַּיהוָה מָגֵן עֶזְרֶךָ
וַאֲשֶׁר חֶרֶב גַּאֲוָתֶךָ וְיִכָּחֲשׁוּ אֹיְבֶיךָ
לָךְ וְאַתָּה עַל בָּמוֹתֵימוֹ תִדְרֹךְ: [i]

For Your salvation I wait, O LORD.[1] He is your praise and He is your God, who has done for you these great and awesome things which your eyes have seen. The LORD your God was unwilling to listen to Balaam, and the LORD your God turned the curse into a blessing for you, because the LORD your God loves you. You shall fear the LORD your God, serve Him, cling to Him,[A] and swear by His name. For I will proclaim the name of the LORD; ascribe greatness to our God. How fortunate you are, O Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD,[2] the shield of your help, and who is the sword of your majesty! Your enemies will cringe before you,[B] and you will tread upon their high places.[C]

(נביאים) וְזָרַקְתִּי עֲלֵיכֶם מַיִם
טְהוֹרִים וּטְהַרְתֶּם מִכֹּל טֻמְאוֹתֵיכֶם
וּמִכָּל גִּלּוּלֵיכֶם אֲטַהֵר אֶתְכֶם:

"I will sprinkle clean water upon you,[3] and you shall be cleansed; from all your impurities and from all your idols I will purify you. And let us know, let

[A] Or: "cleave to Him" — The traditional translation 'cleave to Him' might be preferred in religious contexts as it maintains the archaic religious language that conveys the intensely binding relationship described by the Hebrew 'tidback'. Both translations are accurate, but 'cleave' has deeper religious resonance in English translations of biblical material.

[B] Or: "Your enemies will submit themselves to you" — The Hebrew verb 'yikachashu' has connotations of submission through deception or pretense. While 'cringe' captures the physical posture, 'submit themselves' might better convey the forced acknowledgment of superiority implied in the original.

[C] Or: "their heights" — While 'high places' accurately reflects the primary meaning of 'bamoteimo' in biblical Hebrew (often referring to elevated worship sites), in this context the more general 'heights' might better convey the metaphorical sense of triumph over the enemy's strongholds or points of pride.

[1] This opening verse establishes the prayer's focus on waiting or hoping for divine intervention. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's healing prayers, this represents the sick person's patient expectation of recovery or, if death approaches, divine redemption of the soul.

[2] The compilation of these verses in Ma'avar Yabok's healing prayer sequence transforms national salvation imagery into individual healing contexts. The collective experience of Israel becomes a template for the individual's hope for divine intervention in illness.

[3] This collection of prophetic verses begins with purification imagery that would be particularly relevant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's focus on healing and preparation for death. The progression from purification to restoration reflects the spiritual journey intended for the sick person.

[i] Cf. Genesis 49:18 — This verse's placement at the beginning of this healing prayer collection is significant as it connects the sick person's hope for recovery to Jacob, who is the central figure in the Ma'avar Yabok metaphor (crossing the Yabok River) | Cf. Deuteronomy 10:20-21 — These verses establish the theological foundation for seeking divine healing—the same God who performed awesome deeds in Israel's history is the one being petitioned for healing | Cf. Deuteronomy 23:5 — This verse serves as a powerful example of divine transformation of negative to positive, which would give hope to the ill person that their condition could similarly be transformed from curse to blessing | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:3 — This verse frames the prayer as a proclamation of divine power and greatness, a theme in Ma'avar Yabok that proper prayer involves recognizing God's sovereignty | Cf. Deuteronomy 33:29 — This verse casts illness as an enemy that will ultimately submit to divine power, with the sick person eventually 'treading upon' their affliction just as Israel would triumph over enemies

וְנֵדְעָה נִרְדְּפָה לָדַעַת אֶת יְהוָה
כְּשַׁחַר נָכוֹן מוֹצָאוֹ וְיָבוֹא כַגֶּשֶׁם
לָנוּ כְּמַלְקוֹשׁ יוֹרֶה אָרֶץ: וַיהוָה
1435 אֱלֹהֵי הַצְּבָאוֹת יְהוָה זִכְרוֹ: וְאַתָּה
בֵּאלֹהֶיךָ תָּשׁוּב חֶסֶד וּמִשְׁפָּט שְׁמֹר
וְקַוֵּה אֶל אֱלֹהֶיךָ תָּמִיד: אֶהְיֶה
כַּטָּל לְיִשְׂרָאֵל יִפְרַח כַּשּׁוֹשַׁנָּה וְנָךְ
שָׁרָשָׁיו כַּלְּבָנוֹן: יֵלְכוּ יׇנְקוֹתָיו
1440 וִיהִי כַזַּיִת הוֹדוֹ וְרֵיחַ לוֹ כַּלְּבָנוֹן:
וְאָכַלְתֶּם אָכוֹל וְשָׂבוֹעַ וְהִלַּלְתֶּם
אֶת שֵׁם יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה
עִמָּכֶם לְהַפְלִיא וְלֹא יֵבֹשׁוּ עַמִּי
לְעוֹלָם: וְאַתְּ בְּקוֹל תּוֹדָה אֶזְבְּחָה
1445 לָךְ אֲשֶׁר נָדַרְתִּי אֲשַׁלְּמָה יְשׁוּעָתָה
לַיהוָה: כִּי כָל הָעַמִּים יֵלְכוּ אִישׁ
בְּשֵׁם אֱלֹהָיו וַאֲנַחְנוּ נֵלֵךְ בְּשֵׁם
יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד: תָּרֹם
יָדְךָ עַל צָרֶיךָ וְכָל אוֹיְבֶיךָ יִכָּרֵתוּ:
1450 זַעַף יְהוָה אֶשָּׂא כִּי חָטָאתִי לוֹ עַד
אֲשֶׁר יָרִיב רִיבִי וְעָשָׂה מִשְׁפָּטִי
יוֹצִיאֵנִי לָאוֹר אֶרְאֶה בְּצִדְקָתוֹ:
וַאֲנִי בַּיהוָה אֲצַפֶּה אוֹחִילָה
לֵאלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי יִשְׁמָעֵנִי אֱלֹהָי: [i]

us pursue to know the LORD; His coming forth is as certain as the dawn,[A] and He will come to us like the rain, like the latter rain that waters the earth. And the LORD God of hosts, the LORD is His memorial name. And you, return to your God; maintain 1550R
kindness and justice,[1] and wait for your God continually. I will be like dew to Israel;[2] he shall blossom like a lily, and strike his roots like Lebanon.[B] His shoots shall spread, and his splendor shall be like the olive tree, and his fragrance like Lebanon. You 1555R
shall eat, eat and be satisfied,[C] and you shall praise the name of the LORD your God who has dealt wondrously with you; and My people shall never be put to shame. But as for me, I will sacrifice to You with the voice of thanksgiving; I will fulfill what I have 1560R
vowed. Salvation belongs to the LORD. For all the peoples walk each in the name of its god, but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God forever and ever.[3] Let Your hand be raised against Your adversaries, and may all Your enemies be cut off. I 1565R
will bear the indignation of the LORD[D] because I have sinned against Him, until He pleads my cause and executes justice for me. He will bring me forth

[A] Or: "His appearance is as established as the dawn" — The Hebrew 'nachon' can mean 'certain,' but also 'established' or 'fixed.' This alternate translation emphasizes the reliability and predictability of divine revelation, similar to how the dawn always appears at its appointed time.

[B] Or: "and send down his roots like Lebanon" — The verb 'yach' (from 'nakah') can mean 'strike,' but in this botanical context, it more likely refers to the action of roots growing downward with force. The Lebanon mountains were known for their deeply-rooted cedar trees, so this translation better captures the image of deep, strong root development.

[C] Or: "You shall surely eat and be satisfied" — The repetition of the verb 'eat' (אָכוֹל) after 'you shall eat' (וְאֲכַלְתֶּם) is a Hebrew idiom indicating certainty rather than literal repetition of the action. This translation better conveys the emphatic nature of the promise in English.

[D] Or: "I will endure the LORD's wrath" — While 'indignation' is accurate, 'wrath' more directly conveys the emotional intensity of 'za'af' in modern English. The verb 'endure' also communicates the patient suffering implied in 'essa' (I will bear/carry) in a way that might resonate more clearly with contemporary readers.

[1] The text emphasizes that even during illness, one should continue practicing ethical virtues. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's integrated approach to healing that addresses both physical and spiritual dimensions.

[2] The verses from Hosea employ a series of botanical metaphors (dew, lily, Lebanon cedar, olive tree) that would be understood as representing the gradual but certain process of recovery through divine intervention—from initial moisture (dew) to full growth (Lebanon cedars) to fruitfulness (olive tree).

[3] This verse from Micah 4:5 affirms Jewish distinctiveness and faith commitment even amid suffering, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on maintaining proper spiritual orientation during illness.

[i] Cf. Ezekiel 36:25 — This verse from Ezekiel is used in the context of spiritual purification and healing. In Ma'avar Yabok, it's included as part of prayer sequences for the sick, suggesting that physical healing is connected to spiritual purification. | Cf. Hosea 6:3 — This verse emphasizes the reliability of God's presence like the dawn and rain, providing comfort to the sick with the

to the light; I will see His righteousness.[1] But as for me, I will watch in hope for the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation; my God will hear me."[2]"

(כתובים) עוּרָה לָמָּה תִישַׁן אֲדֹנָי
הָקִיצָה אַל תִּזְנַח לָנֶצַח: לָמָּה פָנֶיךָ
תַסְתִּיר תִּשְׁכַּח עָנְיֵנוּ וְלַחֲצֵנוּ: כִּי
שָׁחָה לֶעָפָר נַפְשֵׁנוּ דָּבְקָה לָאָרֶץ
בִּטְנֵנוּ: קוּמָה עֶזְרָתָה לָנוּ וּפְדֵנוּ
לְמַעַן חַסְדֶּךָ: אֱלֹהִים לָנוּ מַחֲסֶה
וָעֹז עֶזְרָה בְצָרוֹת נִמְצָא מְאֹד:
חַטָּאתִי אוֹדִישֶׁךָ וַעֲוֹנִי לֹא כִסִּיתִי
אָמַרְתִּי אוֹדֶה עֲלֵי פְשָׁעַי לַיהוָה
וְאַתָּה נָשָׂאתָ עֲוֹן חַטָּאתִי סֶלָה:
אָנָּא אֲדֹנָי הָאֵל הַגָּדוֹל וְהַנּוֹרָא
שֹׁמֵר הַבְּרִית וְהַחֶסֶד לְאֹהֲבָיו

(Writings) Awake! Why do You sleep, O Lord? Arise! Do not reject us forever. Why do You hide Your face, forgetting our affliction and our oppression?[A] For our soul is bowed down to the dust; our belly cleaves to the earth.[B] Arise as our help, and redeem us for the sake of Your loving-kindness. God is our refuge and strength, a help in troubles, found most readily. I acknowledge my sin to You, and my iniquity I have not concealed. I said, "I will confess my transgressions to the LORD," and You forgave the iniquity of my sin. Selah.[3] Please, O Lord, the great and awesome God, who keeps

[A] Or: "Why do You hide Your face, and forget our suffering and our distress" — The Hebrew terms 'עָנְיֵנוּ' and 'לַחֲצֵנוּ' can be rendered with slightly different nuances. This alternative uses 'suffering' and 'distress' which may better convey the emotional experience being described in a more accessible modern English.

[B] Or: "For our soul is prostrated to the dust; our body clings to the ground" — The Hebrew 'בִּטְנֵנוּ' literally means 'our belly' but in this context refers to the physical body in a prostrate position. This alternative translation avoids the somewhat archaic 'cleaves' and provides a clearer image of complete prostration in modern English.

[1] The final verses move from acceptance of suffering as deserved (acknowledging sin) to confident expectation of divine vindication and restoration. This spiritual progression models the ideal attitude toward illness in Jewish tradition: humble acceptance followed by hopeful anticipation.

[2] The collection concludes with an expression of quiet confidence that prayer will be heard, providing reassurance to the ill person that their supplications are reaching God despite their current distress.

[3] Selah is a Hebrew musical or liturgical term found in the Psalms whose exact meaning is uncertain. It may indicate a musical interlude, a pause for reflection, or a shift in musical emphasis. In the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, it might serve as a moment of contemplative pause.

assurance that God will come to them reliably in their time of need. | Cf. Hosea 12:5-6 — These verses emphasize God's constancy and the need for the ill person to maintain proper spiritual attributes (kindness and justice) while waiting for divine healing. | Cf. Hosea 14:5-7 — These botanical metaphors for healing and restoration (dew, lily, Lebanon cedar, olive tree) would be understood as representing the gradual but certain process of recovery from illness through divine intervention. | Cf. Joel 2:26 — This verse connects physical restoration (eating and being satisfied) with spiritual response (praising God), suggesting that the sick person should anticipate both physical healing and spiritual renewal. | Cf. Jonah 2:9 — This verse from Jonah's prayer of thanksgiving while still in distress models how the ill person should express gratitude and fulfill vows even before complete healing occurs. | Cf. Micah 4:5 — This verse affirms Jewish distinctiveness and commitment to the true God even in times of suffering, encouraging the ill person to maintain faith in the one true God during their ordeal. | Cf. Micah 5:9 — In the context of illness, this verse would be understood as a prayer for God to raise His hand against the 'enemies' of disease and suffering afflicting the sick person. | Cf. Micah 7:9 — This verse models proper spiritual response to suffering: acknowledging sin, accepting divine discipline, and maintaining hope for eventual redemption and renewal. | Cf. Micah 7:7 — The concluding verse emphasizes hopeful watching and waiting for divine intervention, providing a model of patient endurance for the ill person who must wait for healing.

וּלְשֹׁמְרֵי מִצְוֹתָיו: תִּהְיֶנָא אָזְנְךָ
קַשֻּׁבָת וְעֵינֶיךָ פְּתוּחוֹת לִשְׁמֹעַ אֶל
תְּפִלַּת עַבְדְּךָ אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מִתְפַּלֵּל
לְפָנֶיךָ הַיּוֹם יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה: חָטָאנוּ
וְעָוִינוּ הִרְשַׁעְנוּ וּמָרָדְנוּ וְסוֹר
מִמִּצְוֹתֶךָ וּמִמִּשְׁפָּטֶיךָ: לַאדֹנָי
אֱלֹהֵינוּ הָרַחֲמִים וְהַסְּלִחוֹת כִּי
מָרַדְנוּ בּוֹ: וְעַתָּה שְׁמַע אֱלֹהֵינוּ
אֶל תְּפִלַּת עַבְדְּךָ וְאֶל תַּחֲנוּנָיו
וְהָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ עַל מִקְדָּשְׁךָ הַשָּׁמֵם
לְמַעַן אֲדֹנָי: אֲדֹנָי שְׁמָעָה אֲדֹנָי
סְלָחָה אֲדֹנָי הַקְשִׁיבָה וַעֲשֵׂה
אַל־תְּאַחַר לְמַעַנְךָ אֱלֹהַי כִּי שִׁמְךָ
נִקְרָא עַל עִירְךָ וְעַל עַמֶּךָ: וַאֲנִי
כְּזַיִת רַעֲנָן בְּבֵית אֱלֹהִים בָּטַחְתִּי
בְחֶסֶד אֱלֹהִים עוֹלָם וָעֶד: עָזַרְנוּ
אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ עַל דְּבַר כְּבוֹד שְׁמֶךָ
וְהַצִּילֵנוּ וְכַפֵּר עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ
לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ: אֱלֹהִים הֲשִׁיבֵנוּ וְהָאֵר
פָּנֶיךָ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה: אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת
הֲשִׁיבֵנוּ וְהָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה: יְהוָה
אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת הֲשִׁיבֵנוּ הָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ
וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה: כִּי לַיהוָה מָגִנֵּנוּ וְלִקְדוֹשׁ
יִשְׂרָאֵל מַלְכֵּנוּ: אִם אָמַרְתִּי מָטָה
רַגְלִי חַסְדְּךָ יְהוָה יִסְעָדֵנִי בְּרֹב
שַׂרְעַפַּי בְּקִרְבִּי תַּנְחוּמֶיךָ יְשַׁעְשְׁעוּ
נַפְשִׁי: [i]

the covenant and mercy[1] with those who love Him and keep His commandments. Let Your ear be 1585R
attentive and Your eyes open to hear the prayer of Your servant which I am praying before You today, day and night. We have sinned, we have done wrong, we have acted wickedly, we have rebelled and turned away from Your commandments and Your 1590R
judgments. To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness, for we have rebelled against Him. And now, hear, O our God, the prayer of Your servant and his supplications, and cause Your face to shine upon Your desolate sanctuary[2] for the Lord's sake. 1595R
O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive; O Lord, listen and act! Do not delay, for Your own sake, my God, for Your name is called upon Your city and Your people. And I am like a green olive tree in the house of God; I trust in the mercy of God forever and 1600R
ever. Help us, O God of our salvation,[3] for the glory of Your name; deliver us and atone for our sins, for Your name's sake. O God, restore us, and cause Your face to shine, and we shall be saved. O God of hosts, restore us, and cause Your face to shine, and 1605R
we shall be saved. O LORD God of hosts, restore us; cause Your face to shine, and we shall be saved. For to the LORD belongs our shield, and to the Holy One of Israel, our King. When I said, "My foot slips," Your mercy, O LORD, held me up. In the 1610R

[1] This formulaic language draws from Daniel 9 and appears frequently in Jewish liturgy. In Ma'avar Yabok, invoking God's covenant relationship serves as a basis for requesting healing based on God's established promises rather than personal merit.

[2] While originally referring to the destroyed Temple in Jerusalem in Daniel's prayer, in Ma'avar Yabok's context this may be understood metaphorically to refer to the sick person's body as a desecrated sanctuary that needs divine restoration.

[3] The text shifts between individual ("I") and communal ("we") perspectives. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's understanding that illness affects both the individual and the community, and that healing requires both personal and communal prayer.

[i] Cf. Psalm 44:23-26 — This passage is used in Ma'avar Yabok as a prayer for the sick, with the prostration imagery symbolizing the physical weakness of illness. The text connects physical suffering to spiritual distress, implying that divine awakening will bring healing. | Cf. Psalm 46:1 — In the context of prayers for the sick, this verse serves to strengthen the ill person's faith that God remains their refuge even in severe illness. The phrase 'found most readily' (נִמְצָא מְאֹד) suggests that divine help is particularly accessible during times of distress. | Cf. Psalm 32:5 — This confession verse reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on vidui (confession) for the sick. The book presents illness as potentially resulting from sin, and confession as a necessary spiritual remedy that may lead to physical healing as well. | Cf. Daniel 9:4-19 — Daniel's prayer is adapted here for individual use in times of illness. Ma'avar Yabok frequently draws on biblical models of confession and supplication, with Daniel's prayer being particularly significant as it combines personal and communal elements with references to covenant relationship. | Cf. Psalm 84:10-11 — The threefold repetition of 'restore us' with increasingly elaborate divine titles (God, God of hosts, LORD God of hosts) creates an intensification typical in Jewish prayer. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves to emphasize the desperate need for divine healing through increasingly powerful appeals. | Cf. Psalm

multitude of my anxieties within me, Your comforts delight my soul.[A]

ויאמר למען יחלצון ידידיך וגו׳[i] רפאני ה׳ וגו׳[ii] ככל הסדר הכתוב למעלה עד צורי וגואלי׳[iii][iv]

And he shall say, "That Your beloved ones may be delivered, etc.," "Heal me, O LORD, etc.," following the entire order written above until "my Rock and my Redeemer."[B] 1615R

סדר ח[v]

Order Eight

יתחיל אנא ה׳ הושיעה נא וגו׳[vi] ככתוב למעלה בסדר

He shall begin "Please, O LORD, save us, etc."[C] as written above in the first order,[1] and afterward he

[A] Or: "When my troubling thoughts multiply within me, Your consolations bring joy to my soul" — The Hebrew 'שַׁרְעַפַּי' refers to disquieting or anxious thoughts, and 'יְשַׁעְשְׁעוּ' carries connotations of both delight and comfort. This alternative rendering captures the contrast between internal anxiety and divine consolation more vividly.

[B] Or: "And one should recite "That Your beloved ones may be delivered..." and "Heal me, O LORD..." following the complete liturgical sequence specified above, until the concluding words "my Rock and my Redeemer."" — This alternate translation uses "one should recite" instead of "he shall say" to emphasize the instructional nature of the text, and specifies "complete liturgical sequence" rather than "entire order" to better convey the specialized religious context of these standardized prayer instructions.

[C] Or: "One should begin with "Please, O LORD, save us" and so forth" — This alternative provides a more impersonal instruction that might better reflect the liturgical manual format, using 'one should' rather than 'he shall.' This could be preferred in contexts where gender-neutral language is desired.

[1] This cross-reference demonstrates the practical manual nature of Ma'avar Yabok. Rather than

52:8 — The green olive tree image represents vitality and endurance, contrasting with the illness context. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves as a meditation on the hope of restoration to health and continued spiritual flourishing despite current affliction.

[i] This refers to a standard prayer formula that appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. The abbreviation "'וגו" (etc.) indicates that the reader should recite the complete, familiar prayer without needing it to be written out in full.

[ii] This is a healing prayer formula beginning with "Heal me, O LORD" (from Jeremiah 17:14), which was to be recited in its entirety. The abbreviation indicates that the full, familiar text should be recited.

[iii] This is a liturgical instruction directing the reader to follow the complete prayer sequence that was detailed earlier in the text, reciting everything through the concluding formula "my Rock and my Redeemer" (from Psalm 19:14).

[iv] Cf. Psalm 19:14 — This reference to Psalm 19:14 serves as a standardized closing formula for prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok. By referring to God as both Rock (stability/protection) and Redeemer (salvation/deliverance), it provides a fitting conclusion to prayers for the sick, reinforcing trust in divine protection during illness. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This abbreviated reference to Jeremiah 17:14 is used as a healing formula in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. The verse expresses complete dependence on God for healing and salvation, reinforcing the book's theological framework that true healing comes from divine intervention rather than merely human efforts. | Cf. Psalm 108:7 — This reference to Psalm 108:7 serves as a standard opening formula in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. By beginning with this verse, which asks for divine deliverance of God's beloved ones, the prayer immediately establishes its purpose of seeking divine intervention for the ill person while positioning them among God's beloved.

[v] This heading indicates the beginning of the eighth and final liturgical sequence in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer system for the sick and dying. Each 'seder' (order) follows a similar pattern but contains different psalms and verses appropriate for various situations.

[vi] The abbreviation 'וגו" (etc.) appears multiple times in this passage. It indicates that the reader should continue with the complete text of a familiar prayer or passage without the author needing to write it out in full. This was a common space-saving technique in prayer books and liturgical manuals.

א׳[i] ואחר כך יאמר מזמור ק״ג או ק״ד או קט״ז או קי״ח[ii] ואח״כ יאמר אין כאל וגו׳:[iii]

shall recite Psalm 103 or 104 or 116 or 118,[1] and then he shall say "There is none like God, etc."[A] 1620R

(תהלים קג) לְדָוִד בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי
1505 אֶת־יְיָ[iv] וְכָל־קְרָבַי[v] אֶת־שֵׁם
קָדְשׁוֹ: בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְיָ
וְאַל־תִּשְׁכְּחִי כָּל־גְּמוּלָיו:
הַסֹּלֵחַ לְכָל־עֲוֹנֵכִי הָרֹפֵא
לְכָל־תַּחֲלוּאָיְכִי:[vi] הַגּוֹאֵל מִשַּׁחַת
1510 חַיָּיְכִי הַמְעַטְּרֵכִי חֶסֶד וְרַחֲמִים:
הַמַּשְׂבִּיעַ בַּטּוֹב עֶדְיֵךְ תִּתְחַדֵּשׁ
כַּנֶּשֶׁר נְעוּרָיְכִי:[vii] עֹשֵׂה צְדָקוֹת

(Psalm 103) Of David. Bless the LORD, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless His holy name. Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all His benefits. Who forgives all your iniquities, who heals all your diseases. Who redeems your life from destruction,[2] who crowns you with kindness and compassion. Who satisfies your years with good things, so that your youth is renewed like the eagle. The LORD performs righteous acts and justice for all who are 1625R 1630R

[A] Or: "followed by reciting "There is none like God" and what follows" — This alternative formulation avoids the repetition of 'he shall say' and provides a smoother liturgical instruction in English, which might be preferred in a more flowing translation.

repeating the full prayer text in each section, the author directs readers to where it first appears, creating an efficient reference system for those attending to the sick and dying.

[1] These psalms were selected for their themes of divine healing, protection, deliverance from death, and thanksgiving. Offering options reflects Ma'avar Yabok's approach of providing structured yet flexible prayer sequences that could be adapted to various situations of illness.

[2] The Hebrew 'mi-shaḥat' literally means 'from the pit' or 'from corruption,' which has dual significance in Ma'avar Yabok: it refers both to rescue from physical death and to redemption of the soul from spiritual destruction.

[i] This refers to instructions already provided in the first prayer order (seder). Ma'avar Yabok contains eight distinct prayer sequences (sedarim) for the sick and dying, each with standardized elements. Rather than repeating instructions, the text often refers back to where they first appeared.

[ii] These abbreviations refer to Psalms 103, 104, 116, or 118. Using numerical abbreviations for psalm references was common in traditional Jewish texts.

[iii] Cf. הושיעה נא אנא ה — This phrase is from Psalm 118:25 and serves as the standardized opening formula for each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok. The instruction to begin with this formula indicates that this passage is establishing the structure for one of these formal prayer sequences for the sick or dying. | Cf. ככתוב למעלה בסדר א — This indicates that Ma'avar Yabok uses a system of standardized prayer sequences with consistent elements. Rather than repeating the full opening formula, the text refers readers back to the first sequence where it was fully detailed. This cross-referencing system appears throughout the book as a practical feature to avoid unnecessary repetition. | Cf. אין כאל — This phrase "There is none like God" comes from Deuteronomy 33:26 ("There is none like the God of Jeshurun") and became the opening of a standard prayer used in Jewish liturgy. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it appears to function as a standardized component of the prayer sequences for the sick and dying, creating a consistent framework while allowing flexibility in psalm selection.

[iv] The psalm begins with the reflexive command for the soul to bless God, establishing an internal dialogue that was considered spiritually beneficial for the sick. The repetition of this phrase both opens and closes the psalm, creating a liturgical frame.

[v] The term 'keravai' (my inward parts) refers to the internal organs, which in ancient Jewish thought were associated with emotions and spiritual faculties. In the context of illness, this becomes a call for even the afflicted body parts to participate in praising God.

[vi] This reference to God as healer of all diseases is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as it provides biblical foundation for the book's emphasis on both spiritual and physical healing. The medieval Jewish understanding saw illness as potentially serving both punitive and purificatory functions.

[vii] The metaphor of renewal 'like the eagle' draws on ancient belief that eagles periodically renewed their youth by molting and growing new feathers. In kabbalistic interpretation, this represents both physical healing and spiritual resurrection.

יְיָ וּמִשְׁפָּטִים לְכָל־עֲשׁוּקִים׃
יוֹדִיעַ דְּרָכָיו לְמֹשֶׁה לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
עֲלִילוֹתָיו׃ רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן יְיָ אֶרֶךְ
אַפַּיִם וְרַב־חֶסֶד׃ לֹא־לָנֶצַח יָרִיב
וְלֹא לְעוֹלָם יִטּוֹר׃ לֹא כַחֲטָאֵינוּ
עָשָׂה לָנוּ וְלֹא כַעֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ גָּמַל
עָלֵינוּ׃ כִּי כִגְבֹהַּ שָׁמַיִם עַל־הָאָרֶץ
גָּבַר חַסְדּוֹ עַל־יְרֵאָיו׃ כִּרְחֹק
מִזְרָח מִמַּעֲרָב הִרְחִיק מִמֶּנּוּ
אֶת־פִּשָׁעֵינוּ׃ כְּרַחֵם אָב עַל־בָּנִים
רִחַם יְיָ עַל־יְרֵאָיו׃ כִּי־הוּא יָדַע
יִצְרֵנוּ זָכוּר כִּי־עָפָר אֲנָחְנוּ׃ אֱנוֹשׁ
כֶּחָצִיר יָמָיו כְּצִיץ הַשָּׂדֶה כֵּן
יָצִיץ׃ כִּי רוּחַ עָבְרָה־בּוֹ וְאֵינֶנּוּ
וְלֹא־יַכִּירֶנּוּ עוֹד מְקוֹמוֹ׃ וְחֶסֶד
יְיָ מֵעוֹלָם וְעַד־עוֹלָם עַל־יְרֵאָיו
וְצִדְקָתוֹ לִבְנֵי בָנִים׃ לְשֹׁמְרֵי
בְרִיתוֹ וּלְזֹכְרֵי פִקֻּדָיו לַעֲשׂוֹתָם׃
יְיָ בַּשָּׁמַיִם הֵכִין כִּסְאוֹ וּמַלְכוּתוֹ
בַּכֹּל מָשָׁלָה׃ בָּרְכוּ יְיָ מַלְאָכָיו
גִּבֹּרֵי כֹחַ עֹשֵׂי דְבָרוֹ לִשְׁמֹעַ
בְּקוֹל דְּבָרוֹ׃ בָּרְכוּ יְיָ כָּל־צְבָאָיו
מְשָׁרְתָיו עֹשֵׂי רְצוֹנוֹ׃ בָּרְכוּ יְיָ
כָּל־מַעֲשָׂיו בְּכָל־מְקֹמוֹת מֶמְשַׁלְתּוֹ
בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְיָ׃ [i]

oppressed. He made known His ways to Moses, His deeds to the children of Israel. The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger and abundant in kindness. He will not contend forever,[1] nor will He harbor resentment eternally. He has not dealt with us according to our sins, nor repaid us according to our iniquities. For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is His kindness toward those who fear Him. As far as the east is from the west, so far has He removed our transgressions from us. As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our nature; He remembers that we are dust. Man's days are like grass; like a flower of the field, so he flourishes. For the wind passes over it, and it is gone, and its place recognizes it no more. But the kindness of the LORD is from everlasting to everlasting upon those who fear Him, and His righteousness to children's children. To those who keep His covenant and remember His precepts to do them. The LORD has established His throne in the heavens, and His kingdom rules over all. Bless the LORD, O His angels, mighty in strength,[2] who perform His word, hearkening to the voice of His word. Bless the LORD, all His hosts, His ministers who do His will. Bless the LORD, all His works, in all places of His dominion; bless the LORD, O my soul.

1635R 1640R 1645R 1650R 1655R

(תהלים קד) בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְיָ
יְיָ אֱלֹהַי גָּדַלְתָּ מְאֹד הוֹד וְהָדָר
לָבָשְׁתָּ׃ עֹטֶה־אוֹר כַּשַּׂלְמָה נוֹטֶה

(Psalm 104) Bless the LORD, O my soul. O LORD my God, You are very great; You are clothed with glory and majesty. You wrap Yourself in light as

1660R

[1] The Hebrew verb 'yariv' (contend/strive) carries juridical connotations, suggesting God as judge. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that presents illness as divine judgment that is ultimately limited by divine mercy.

[2] The Hebrew 'gibborei koaḥ' (mighty in strength) refers to the angels, who in Jewish mystical tradition were understood as the agents carrying out divine will, including healing. Ma'avar Yabok includes extensive discussions of angelic intervention in healing and in guiding souls after death.

[i] Cf. Psalm 103 — This psalm is included in Ma'avar Yabok as part of the structured prayer sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying. It appears in the sixth liturgical order (Seder Vav) and emphasizes divine forgiveness, healing, compassion, and the transient nature of human life—all themes particularly relevant to those facing serious illness or approaching death. | Cf. Psalm 103:3-5 — These verses are especially significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context as they directly address healing, redemption from death, and renewal—central concerns for the sick and dying. The imagery of renewal 'like the eagle' would be understood as representing the hope for both physical healing and spiritual resurrection. | Cf. Psalm 103:14-16 — These verses on human mortality and fragility serve as a meditation on the transient nature of life, which would be particularly poignant for those facing death. In Ma'avar Yabok, such reflections are not meant to induce despair but rather to encourage proper spiritual preparation and acceptance of divine judgment.

שָׁמַיִם כַּיְרִיעָה: הַמְקָרֶה בַמַּיִם
עֲלִיּוֹתָיו הַשָּׂם־עָבִים רְכוּבוֹ
הַמְהַלֵּךְ עַל־כַּנְפֵי־רוּחַ: עֹשֶׂה
מַלְאָכָיו רוּחוֹת מְשָׁרְתָיו אֵשׁ
לֹהֵט: יָסַד־אֶרֶץ עַל־מְכוֹנֶיהָ
בַּל־תִּמּוֹט עוֹלָם וָעֶד: תְּהוֹם
כַּלְבוּשׁ כִּסִּיתוֹ עַל־הָרִים יַעַמְדוּ
מָיִם: מִן־גַּעֲרָתְךָ יְנוּסוּן מִן־קוֹל
רַעַמְךָ יֵחָפֵזוּן: יַעֲלוּ הָרִים יֵרְדוּ
בְקָעוֹת אֶל־מְקוֹם זֶה יָסַדְתָּ לָהֶם:
גְּבוּל־שַׂמְתָּ בַל־יַעֲבֹרוּן בַּל־יְשֻׁבוּן
לְכַסּוֹת הָאָרֶץ: הַמְשַׁלֵּחַ מַעְיָנִים
בַּנְּחָלִים בֵּין הָרִים יְהַלֵּכוּן: יַשְׁקוּ
כָּל־חַיְתוֹ שָׂדָי יִשְׁבְּרוּ פְרָאִים
צְמָאָם: עֲלֵיהֶם עוֹף־הַשָּׁמַיִם יִשְׁכּוֹן
מִבֵּין עֳפָאִים יִתְּנוּ־קוֹל: מַשְׁקֶה
הָרִים מֵעֲלִיּוֹתָיו מִפְּרִי מַעֲשֶׂיךָ
תִּשְׂבַּע הָאָרֶץ: מַצְמִיחַ חָצִיר
לַבְּהֵמָה וְעֵשֶׂב לַעֲבֹדַת הָאָדָם
לְהוֹצִיא לֶחֶם מִן־הָאָרֶץ: וְיַיִן
יְשַׂמַּח לְבַב־אֱנוֹשׁ לְהַצְהִיל פָּנִים
מִשָּׁמֶן [i] וְלֶחֶם לְבַב־אֱנוֹשׁ יִסְעָד:
יִשְׂבְּעוּ עֲצֵי יְיָ אַרְזֵי לְבָנוֹן אֲשֶׁר
נָטָע: אֲשֶׁר־שָׁם צִפֳּרִים יְקַנֵּנוּ
חֲסִידָה בְּרוֹשִׁים בֵּיתָהּ: הָרִים
הַגְּבֹהִים לַיְעֵלִים סְלָעִים מַחְסֶה
לַשְׁפַנִּים: עָשָׂה יָרֵחַ לְמוֹעֲדִים
שֶׁמֶשׁ יָדַע מְבוֹאוֹ: תָּשֶׁת־חֹשֶׁךְ וְיִהִי
לָיְלָה בּוֹ־תִרְמֹשׂ כָּל־חַיְתוֹ־יָעַר:
הַכְּפִירִים שֹׁאֲגִים לַטָּרֶף וּלְבַקֵּשׁ
מֵאֵל אָכְלָם: תִּזְרַח הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ יֵאָסֵפוּן
וְאֶל־מְעוֹנֹתָם יִרְבָּצוּן: יֵצֵא אָדָם
לְפָעֳלוֹ וְלַעֲבֹדָתוֹ עֲדֵי־עָרֶב:
מָה־רַבּוּ מַעֲשֶׂיךָ יְיָ כֻּלָּם בְּחָכְמָה
עָשִׂיתָ מָלְאָה הָאָרֶץ קִנְיָנֶךָ: זֶה הַיָּם
גָּדוֹל וּרְחַב יָדָיִם שָׁם־רֶמֶשׂ וְאֵין
מִסְפָּר חַיּוֹת קְטַנּוֹת עִם־גְּדֹלוֹת:
שָׁם אֳנִיּוֹת יְהַלֵּכוּן לִוְיָתָן זֶה־יָצַרְתָּ

with a garment;[1] You stretch out the heavens like a curtain. You set the beams of Your upper chambers in the waters; You make the clouds Your chariot; You walk upon the wings of the wind. You make the
1545 winds Your messengers, flames of fire Your ministers. 1665R
You established the earth upon its foundations, so that it shall never be moved. You covered it with the deep as with a garment; the waters stood above the mountains. At Your rebuke they fled; at the sound
1550 of Your thunder they hurried away. The mountains 1670R
rose, the valleys sank down to the place which You established for them. You set a boundary that they may not cross, so that they will not return to cover the earth. You send forth springs in the valleys; they
1555 flow between the mountains. They give drink to ev- 1675R
ery beast of the field; the wild donkeys quench their thirst. Beside them the birds of the heavens dwell; they lift their voices from among the branches. You water the mountains from Your upper chambers; the
1560 earth is satisfied with the fruit of Your works. You 1680R
cause grass to grow for the cattle, and vegetation for the labor of man, so that he may bring forth food from the earth, and wine that gladdens the heart of man, oil to make his face shine, and bread that sus-
1565 tains man's heart. The trees of the LORD are well 1685R
watered, the cedars of Lebanon which He planted, where birds make their nests; the stork has her home in the cypresses. The high mountains are for the wild goats; the rocks are a refuge for the rock badgers. He
1570 made the moon for the seasons; the sun knows its 1690R
setting. You bring darkness, and it becomes night, in which all the beasts of the forest prowl. The young lions roar for their prey and seek their food from God. When the sun rises, they withdraw and lie down in
1575 their dens. Man goes forth to his work and to his 1695R
labor until evening.[2] How manifold are Your works, O LORD! In wisdom You have made them all; the earth is full of Your possessions. This is the sea, great

[1] This image of God cloaked in light is significant in kabbalistic thought, where divine light (or) represents God's emanation into the world. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse suggests the divine healing light that might surround the ill person.

[2] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse about the daily rhythm of human life takes on poignant meaning, as it reflects on the regular patterns that illness disrupts and that the dying person will soon leave behind.

[i] The phrase literally means "to make faces shine from oil" and refers to the ancient practice of anointing with oil, which made the face gleam. This is presented as one of the divine gifts that brings joy to humanity.

לְשַׁחֵק־בּוֹ׃[i] כֻּלָּם אֵלֶיךָ יְשַׂבֵּרוּן
לָתֵת אָכְלָם בְּעִתּוֹ׃ תִּתֵּן לָהֶם
יִלְקֹטוּן תִּפְתַּח יָדְךָ יִשְׂבְּעוּן
טוֹב׃ תַּסְתִּיר פָּנֶיךָ יִבָּהֲלוּן תֹּסֵף
רוּחָם יִגְוָעוּן וְאֶל־עֲפָרָם יְשׁוּבוּן׃
תְּשַׁלַּח רוּחֲךָ יִבָּרֵאוּן וּתְחַדֵּשׁ פְּנֵי
אֲדָמָה׃[ii] יְהִי כְבוֹד יְיָ לְעוֹלָם
יִשְׂמַח יְיָ בְּמַעֲשָׂיו׃ הַמַּבִּיט לָאָרֶץ
וַתִּרְעָד יִגַּע בֶּהָרִים וְיֶעֱשָׁנוּ׃
אָשִׁירָה לַיהוָה בְּחַיָּי אֲזַמְּרָה
לֵאלֹהַי בְּעוֹדִי׃ יֶעֱרַב עָלָיו שִׂיחִי
אָנֹכִי אֶשְׂמַח בַּיהוָה׃ יִתַּמּוּ חַטָּאִים
מִן־הָאָרֶץ וּרְשָׁעִים עוֹד אֵינָם
בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת־יְיָ הַלְלוּ־יָהּ׃[iii]

and broad, in which are swarms without number, living creatures both small and great. There the ships move along, and Leviathan, which You have formed to sport in it. They all wait for You to give them their food in due season. When You give it to them, they gather it up; when You open Your hand, they are satisfied with good. When You hide Your face, they are dismayed; when You take away their breath, they die and return to their dust.[1] When You send forth Your spirit, they are created;[2] and You renew the face of the ground. May the glory of the LORD endure forever; may the LORD rejoice in His works. He looks at the earth, and it trembles; He touches the mountains, and they smoke. I will sing to the LORD as long as I live; I will sing praise to my God while I have my being. May my meditation be pleasing to Him; I will rejoice in the LORD. Let sinners be consumed from the earth, and let the wicked be no more. Bless the LORD, O my soul. Hallelujah.

(תהלים קטז) אָהַבְתִּי כִּי־יִשְׁמַע
יְיָ אֶת־קוֹלִי תַּחֲנוּנָי׃ כִּי־הִטָּה
אָזְנוֹ לִי וּבְיָמַי אֶקְרָא׃ אֲפָפוּנִי
חֶבְלֵי־מָוֶת[iv] וּמְצָרֵי שְׁאוֹל מְצָאוּנִי
צָרָה וְיָגוֹן אֶמְצָא׃ וּבְשֵׁם־יְיָ אֶקְרָא
אָנָּה יְיָ מַלְּטָה נַפְשִׁי׃ חַנּוּן יְיָ
וְצַדִּיק וֵאלֹהֵינוּ מְרַחֵם׃ שֹׁמֵר
פְּתָאיִם יְיָ דַּלֹּתִי וְלִי יְהוֹשִׁיעַ׃

(Psalm 116) I love that the LORD hears my voice, my supplications. Because He has inclined His ear to me, I will call upon Him all my days. The cords of death entangled me, the straits of the grave found me; I encountered distress and sorrow. Then I called upon the name of the LORD: "O LORD, I implore You, deliver my soul!" Gracious is the LORD and righteous, and our God is merciful. The LORD

[1] This verse directly addresses mortality as part of divine design, acknowledging that death is part of God's ordained natural order. In Ma'avar Yabok, this recognition would help the dying person accept their situation as part of the cosmic plan.

[2] The Hebrew word 'ruach' means both 'spirit' and 'breath,' creating a powerful connection between divine breath giving life at creation and the breath of life that is ebbing in the sick person. This verse suggests the possibility of renewal even after death.

[i] There is ambiguity in the Hebrew about whether God created Leviathan to play in the sea, or whether God created Leviathan to play with. In kabbalistic texts, Leviathan has significant mystical meaning as a primordial creature.

[ii] This verse about renewal of the earth through divine spirit (ruach) would have particular resonance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and death, as it suggests the possibility of revival and restoration through divine intervention.

[iii] Cf. Zohar — In Ma'avar Yabok, Psalm 104 serves as a meditation on divine creation and order, reinforcing how the same God who maintains the cosmos can also restore health to the ill person or guide the soul in its transition after death. | Cf. Genesis creation narrative — This psalm recounts God's orderly creation and maintenance of the world, providing reassurance to the sick or dying that the same God who created and sustains the universe also oversees human life and death with purpose and wisdom. | Cf. Shabbat liturgy — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok connects the sick person's experience to the larger cosmic and liturgical cycles, suggesting that illness and healing are part of the divine order that governs all creation.

[iv] The Hebrew term 'chevlei mavet' (cords of death) is a vivid metaphor depicting death as something that binds or entangles a person. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would be interpreted as referring to the physical and spiritual bonds that restrict the soul during serious illness.

שׁוּבִי נַפְשִׁי לִמְנוּחָיְכִי כִּי־יְיָ גָּמַל
עָלָיְכִי: כִּי חִלַּצְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מִמָּוֶת
אֶת־עֵינִי מִן־דִּמְעָה אֶת־רַגְלִי
מִדֶּחִי: אֶתְהַלֵּךְ לִפְנֵי יְיָ בְּאַרְצוֹת
1605 הַחַיִּים: הֶאֱמַנְתִּי כִּי אֲדַבֵּר אֲנִי עָנִיתִי מְאֹד: אֲנִי אָמַרְתִּי בְחָפְזִי כָּל־הָאָדָם כֹּזֵב[i]: מָה־אָשִׁיב לַיהוָה כָּל־תַּגְמוּלוֹהִי עָלָי: כּוֹס־יְשׁוּעוֹת אֶשָּׂא וּבְשֵׁם יְיָ אֶקְרָא: נְדָרַי לַיהוָה
1610 אֲשַׁלֵּם נֶגְדָּה־נָּא לְכָל־עַמּוֹ: יָקָר בְּעֵינֵי יְיָ הַמָּוְתָה לַחֲסִידָיו[ii]: אָנָּה יְיָ כִּי־אֲנִי עַבְדֶּךָ אֲנִי־עַבְדְּךָ בֶּן־אֲמָתֶךָ פִּתַּחְתָּ לְמוֹסֵרָי: לְךָ־אֶזְבַּח זֶבַח תּוֹדָה וּבְשֵׁם
1615 יְיָ אֶקְרָא: נְדָרַי לַיהוָה אֲשַׁלֵּם נֶגְדָּה־נָּא לְכָל־עַמּוֹ: בְּחַצְרוֹת בֵּית יְיָ בְּתוֹכֵכִי יְרוּשָׁלָם הַלְלוּ־יָהּ: [iii]

preserves the simple; when I was brought low, He saved me.[A] Return to your rest, O my soul, for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you. For You have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling. I shall walk before 1730R
the LORD in the lands of the living.[1] I believed, therefore I spoke, though I was greatly afflicted. I said in my alarm, "All mankind is deceitful."[B] How can I repay the LORD for all His benefits toward me? I will lift up the cup of salvation[2] and call 1735R
upon the name of the LORD. I will fulfill my vows to the LORD now in the presence of all His people.[3] Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of His faithful ones.[C] O LORD, truly I am Your servant; I am Your servant, the son of Your 1740R
handmaid; You have loosed my bonds. I will offer to You a sacrifice of thanksgiving and call upon the name of the LORD. I will fulfill my vows to

[A] Or: "The LORD protects the innocent; I was weakened, and He saved me" — The term 'petayim' (פְּתָאִים) can refer to the 'simple' but also carries connotations of innocence or naivety. 'Daloti' (דַּלּוֹתִי) literally means 'I was impoverished/weakened.' This alternative emphasizes the vulnerable state of illness that would be particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the sick.

[B] Or: "I said in my haste, "All humanity is unreliable"" — The term 'b'chofzi' (בְּחָפְזִי) refers to a state of panic, haste or alarm, while 'kozev' (כֹּזֵב) can mean 'deceitful,' 'false,' or more broadly 'unreliable.' This alternate translation emphasizes the psalmist's momentary loss of faith in human reliability when facing mortality, which connects to Ma'avar Yabok's theme of finding divine rather than human support in times of crisis.

[C] Or: "Costly in the LORD's sight is the death of His devoted ones" — The Hebrew 'yakar' can mean both 'precious' (valued) and 'costly/dear' (representing a significant loss). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, both meanings enrich the interpretation—death is both valued by God as a sacred transition and recognized as a significant event requiring proper ritual attention.

[1] The phrase 'in the lands of the living' (בְּאַרְצוֹת הַחַיִּים) would have special resonance in Ma'avar Yabok's context. It suggests both continued life in this world after recovery from illness and also the afterlife in the World to Come (Olam Haba), reflecting the book's dual concern with both healing the sick and preparing the soul for its journey after death.

[2] The 'cup of salvation' (כּוֹס־יְשׁוּעוֹת) serves as a powerful ritual metaphor. In liturgical contexts, it represents the third cup of wine at the Passover Seder, while in Ma'avar Yabok's framework, it would symbolize how proper ritual actions serve as vehicles for divine deliverance from illness or a peaceful transition in death.

[3] The fulfillment of vows (נְדָרַי) has special significance in the context of illness, as it was common practice to make vows during sickness promising charitable or religious acts in exchange for recovery. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes the importance of fulfilling such vows, as mentioned in the memory notes on the annulment of vows for the sick.

[i] This phrase reflects a moment of existential crisis where the psalmist, facing mortality, expresses a loss of faith in human reliability. The Hebrew 'b'chofzi' conveys a state of alarm or panicked haste, while the declaration about all humanity being 'kozev' (deceitful/unreliable) represents the profound spiritual disorientation that can accompany serious illness.

[ii] This verse is particularly significant in the context of Jewish approaches to death, offering theological comfort by suggesting that the death of the righteous is not a tragedy but rather something valued in God's eyes. The Hebrew term 'yakar' carries connotations of both 'precious' and 'costly,' creating a rich ambiguity that acknowledges both the value and the gravity of death.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — Psalm 116 appears in the liturgical sequences of Ma'avar Yabok as one of

the LORD now in the presence of all His people, in the courts of the LORD's house, in your midst, O Jerusalem. Hallelujah! 1745R

(תהלים קיח) הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה כִּי־טוֹב כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ׃
יֹאמַר־נָא יִשְׂרָאֵל כִּי לְעוֹלָם 1620
חַסְדּוֹ׃ יֹאמְרוּ־נָא בֵית־אַהֲרֹן כִּי
לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ׃ יֹאמְרוּ־נָא יִרְאֵי
יְיָ כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ׃ מִן־הַמֵּצַר
קָרָאתִי יָהּ עָנָנִי בַמֶּרְחָב יָהּ׃ יְיָ לִי
לֹא אִירָא מַה־יַּעֲשֶׂה לִי אָדָם׃ יְיָ 1625
לִי בְּעֹזְרָי וַאֲנִי אֶרְאֶה בְשֹׂנְאָי׃ טוֹב
לַחֲסוֹת בַּיהוָה מִבְּטֹחַ בָּאָדָם׃ טוֹב
לַחֲסוֹת בַּיהוָה מִבְּטֹחַ בִּנְדִיבִים׃
כָּל־גּוֹיִם סְבָבוּנִי בְּשֵׁם יְיָ כִּי
אֲמִילַם׃ סַבּוּנִי גַם־סְבָבוּנִי בְּשֵׁם 1630
יְיָ כִּי אֲמִילַם׃ סַבּוּנִי כִדְבוֹרִים
דֹּעֲכוּ כְּאֵשׁ קוֹצִים בְּשֵׁם יְיָ כִּי
אֲמִילַם׃ דַּחֹה דְחִיתַנִי לִנְפֹּל וַיהוָה
עֲזָרָנִי׃ עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ וַיְהִי־לִי 1635
לִישׁוּעָה׃ קוֹל רִנָּה וִישׁוּעָה בְּאָהֳלֵי
צַדִּיקִים יְמִין יְיָ עֹשָׂה חָיִל׃ יְמִין
יְיָ רוֹמֵמָה יְמִין יְיָ עֹשָׂה חָיִל׃
לֹא־אָמוּת כִּי־אֶחְיֶה וַאֲסַפֵּר מַעֲשֵׂי
יָהּ׃ יַסֹּר יִסְּרַנִּי יָהּ וְלַמָּוֶת לֹא 1640
נְתָנָנִי׃ פִּתְחוּ־לִי שַׁעֲרֵי־צֶדֶק
אָבֹא־בָם אוֹדֶה יָהּ׃ זֶה־הַשַּׁעַר
לַיהוָה צַדִּיקִים יָבֹאוּ בוֹ׃ אוֹדְךָ

(Psalm 118) Give thanks to the LORD, for He is good, for His loving-kindness endures forever. Let Israel now say: "His loving-kindness endures forever." Let the house of Aaron now say: "His loving-kindness endures forever." Let those who fear the LORD now say: "His loving-kindness endures forever." From distress I called upon the LORD; the LORD answered me with expansiveness.[1] The LORD is for me; I will not fear. What can man do to me? The LORD is for me, among my helpers; therefore I will look upon those who hate me. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in nobles. All nations surrounded me; in the name of the LORD I will cut them off. They surrounded me, yes, they surrounded me; in the name of the LORD I will cut them off. They surrounded me like bees; they were extinguished like a fire of thorns;[2] in the name of the LORD I will cut them off. You pushed me hard that I might fall, but the LORD helped me. The LORD is my strength and song, and He has become my salvation. The voice of rejoicing and salvation is in the tents of the righteous; the right hand of the LORD does valiantly. The right hand of the LORD is exalted; the right hand of the LORD does valiantly. 1750R 1755R 1760R 1765R 1770R

[1] The Hebrew creates a powerful contrast between 'מִן־הַמֵּצַר' (from the narrow place/confinement) and 'בַּמֶּרְחָב' (in the broad place/expansiveness), suggesting not just rescue but transformation from constriction to freedom.

[2] The simile of bees suggests not just encirclement but painful, threatening attack from multiple directions. The image of being quickly extinguished like burning thorns (which flare up but quickly burn out) suggests the transitory nature of the threat despite its initial intensity.

the recommended psalms for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine deliverance from death, thanksgiving for salvation, and commitment to fulfill vows make it particularly appropriate for healing prayers and for those facing mortality. | Cf. Traditional Jewish Liturgy — Psalm 116 is part of the Hallel prayer sequence recited on festivals and special occasions. Its inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok shows how the author repurposes familiar liturgical elements for the specific context of illness and approaching death. | Cf. Zohar — The psalm's references to 'cords of death' (חֶבְלֵי־מָוֶת) and 'straits of the grave' (מְצָרֵי שְׁאוֹל) would be interpreted kabbalistically in Ma'avar Yabok as referring to the soul's journey and the dangers it faces during the transition from life to death, which aligns with the book's central metaphor of 'crossing the Yabok.' | Cf. Talmud — The Talmud connects the phrase 'cup of salvation' (כּוֹס־יְשׁוּעוֹת) to the third cup of wine at the Passover Seder. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would symbolize how proper ritual action serves as a vehicle for divine deliverance, particularly at critical life transitions. | Cf. Traditional Jewish Death Rituals — The phrase 'Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of His faithful ones' (יָקָר בְּעֵינֵי יְיָ הַמָּוְתָה לַחֲסִידָיו) is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as it provides theological comfort that death, when properly approached through religious ritual, is not a tragedy but a valued transition in divine eyes.

כִּי עֲנִיתָנִי וַתְּהִי־לִי לִישׁוּעָה: אֶבֶן
מָאֲסוּ הַבּוֹנִים הָיְתָה לְרֹאשׁ פִּנָּה:
מֵאֵת יְיָ הָיְתָה זֹּאת הִיא נִפְלָאת
בְּעֵינֵינוּ: זֶה־הַיּוֹם עָשָׂה יְיָ נָגִילָה
וְנִשְׂמְחָה בוֹ: אָנָּא יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה
נָּא אָנָּא יְיָ הַצְלִיחָה נָּא: בָּרוּךְ
הַבָּא בְּשֵׁם יְיָ בֵּרַכְנוּכֶם מִבֵּית
יְיָ: אֵל יְיָ וַיָּאֶר לָנוּ אִסְרוּ־חַג
בַּעֲבֹתִים עַד־קַרְנוֹת הַמִּזְבֵּחַ:
אֵלִי אַתָּה וְאוֹדֶךָּ אֱלֹהַי אֲרוֹמְמֶךָּ:
הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה כִּי־טוֹב כִּי לְעוֹלָם
חַסְדּוֹ: [i]

I shall not die, but live, and recount the deeds of the LORD. The LORD has disciplined me severely, but He has not given me over to death. Open to me the gates of righteousness; I will enter through 1775R
them and give thanks to the LORD. This is the gate of the LORD; the righteous will enter through it. I thank You for You have answered me, and You have become my salvation. The stone which the builders rejected has become the chief cornerstone. This is 1780R
from the LORD; it is wondrous in our eyes. This is the day which the LORD has made; let us rejoice and be glad in it. Please, O LORD, save us! Please, O LORD, grant us success! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD; we bless you from the 1785R
house of the LORD. The LORD is God, and He has given us light; bind the festival sacrifice with cords to the horns of the altar.[1] You are my God, and I will thank You; my God, I will exalt You. Give thanks to the LORD, for He is good, for His loving-kindness 1790R
endures forever.

(תורה) אֵין כָּאֵל יְשֻׁרוּן רֹכֵב
שָׁמַיִם בְּעֶזְרֶךָ וּבְגַאֲוָתוֹ שְׁחָקִים:
כִּי יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם הוּא אֱלֹהֵי
הָאֱלֹהִים וַאֲדֹנֵי הָאֲדֹנִים הָאֵל
הַגָּדֹל הַגִּבֹּר וְהַנּוֹרָא אֲשֶׁר לֹא
יִשָּׂא פָנִים וְלֹא יִקַּח שֹׁחַד: כִּי
עַם קָדוֹשׁ אַתָּה לַיהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ
וּבְךָ בָּחַר יְהוָה לִהְיוֹת לוֹ לְעַם
סְגֻלָּה מִכֹּל הָעַמִּים אֲשֶׁר עַל פְּנֵי

(From the Torah) There is none like the God of Jeshurun, who rides through the heavens to help you,[2] and in His majesty through the skies. For the LORD your God is God of gods and Lord of lords, 1795R
the great, mighty, and awesome God, who shows no partiality and accepts no bribes. For you are a holy people to the LORD your God, and the LORD has chosen you to be His treasured people from all the nations on the face of the earth. And to set you high 1800R

[1] This verse has been interpreted in various ways, either as instructions for binding festival sacrifices to the altar with cords, or as a procession of celebrants with branches or palm fronds approaching the altar. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, such Temple imagery would be spiritualized as the soul's approach to divine realms.

[2] This dramatic image of God as a divine warrior riding through the heavens to bring help would be particularly comforting to someone facing illness or approaching death, as it portrays God actively intervening on behalf of the suffering individual.

[i] Cf. Psalms — Psalm 118 is included in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequence as a powerful expression of trust in divine salvation despite surrounding dangers. Its themes of divine deliverance, thanksgiving, and the temporary nature of suffering make it particularly appropriate for those experiencing serious illness or facing death. The psalm's declarations of confidence that 'I shall not die but live' would have special resonance in this context. | Cf. Temple worship — The psalm's references to Temple worship (gates of righteousness, festival sacrifices, altar) would be interpreted in Ma'avar Yabok's context as symbolic of the soul's approach to divine realms, particularly relevant as the sick person contemplates potential transition to the afterlife. These Temple motifs are consistently reinterpreted throughout the book as spiritual journeys rather than physical rituals. | Cf. Hallel prayer sequence — Within Ma'avar Yabok, the inclusion of this psalm from the Hallel sequence connects individual suffering to communal celebration, suggesting that even in illness, the individual remains part of the broader covenant community. This reflects the book's consistent integration of individual spiritual experience with communal religious practice.

הָאֲדָמָה: וּלְתִתְךָ עֶלְיוֹן עַל כָּל
1665 הַגּוֹיִם אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה לִתְהִלָּה וּלְשֵׁם
וּלְתִפְאֶרֶת וְלִהְיוֹתְךָ עַם קָדֹשׁ
לַיהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר: מְעֹנָה
אֱלֹהֵי קֶדֶם וּמִתַּחַת זְרֹעֹת עוֹלָם
וַיְגָרֶשׁ מִפָּנֶיךָ אוֹיֵב וַיֹּאמֶר הַשְׁמֵד:
1670 הַנִּסְתָּרֹת לַיהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְהַנִּגְלֹת
לָנוּ וּלְבָנֵינוּ עַד עוֹלָם לַעֲשׂוֹת אֶת
כָּל דִּבְרֵי הַתּוֹרָה הַזֹּאת: [i]

above all the nations which He has made, for praise, fame, and glory, and for you to be a holy people to the LORD your God, as He has spoken. The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms; He drove out the enemy before you 1805R and said, "Destroy!" The secret things belong to the LORD our God,[1] but the things revealed belong to us and to our children forever, that we may follow all the words of this Torah.

(נביאים) בְּרִיתִי הָיְתָה אִתּוֹ
הַחַיִּים וְהַשָּׁלוֹם וָאֶתְּנֵם לוֹ
1675 מוֹרָא וַיִּירָאֵנִי וּמִפְּנֵי שְׁמִי נֶחָת
הוּא: [ii] וְגִבְרְתִּים בַּיהוָה וּבְשִׁמוֹ
יִתְהַלָּכוּ נְאֻם יְהוָה: וַאֲנִי בַּיהוָה
אֶעְלוֹזָה אָגִילָה בֵּאלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי:
יְהוָה אֲדֹנָי חֵילִי וַיָּשֶׂם רַגְלַי
1680 כָּאַיָּלוֹת [iii] וְעַל בָּמוֹתַי יַדְרִכֵנִי
לַמְנַצֵּחַ בִּנְגִינוֹתַי: [iv] חֶסֶר יְהוָה
מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ פְּנֵה אֹהֵב מֶלֶךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל

(Prophets) My covenant with him was life and 1810R peace,[2] and I gave them to him as fear, and he feared Me, and he was reverent before My name.[A] And I will strengthen them in the LORD, and in His name they shall walk, declares the LORD. But I will exult in the LORD; I will rejoice 1815R in the God of my salvation. The LORD God is my strength, and He makes my feet like hinds' feet, and He leads me upon my high places, for the Chief Musician on my stringed instruments. The LORD

[A] Or: "and he was humbled before My name" — The Hebrew verb נָחַת (nichat) can indicate being subdued, humbled, or brought low. While 'reverent' captures the spiritual attitude, 'humbled' more directly reflects the literal meaning of being lowered or brought down in awe.

[1] This acknowledgment of divine mystery would be especially relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as it provides a theological framework for accepting the unknown aspects of illness, suffering, and death while focusing on what has been revealed through Torah.

[2] This opening verse from Malachi 2:5 refers to God's covenant with the priestly tribe of Levi, though in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it takes on additional significance regarding the covenant between God and those who properly prepare for death.

[i] Cf. Deuteronomy 33:26-27 — This verse describes God as the protector of Israel (Jeshurun), riding through the heavens to help His people. In Ma'avar Yabok, this powerful image of divine protection would provide comfort to the sick or dying person. | Cf. Deuteronomy 10:17 — This verse emphasizes God's supreme authority and perfect justice, reminding the sick person that God is ultimately fair and trustworthy even in times of suffering. | Cf. Deuteronomy 7:6 — This verse reminds the sick person of their spiritual identity as part of God's chosen people, providing comfort through belonging to a covenantal relationship with God. | Cf. Deuteronomy 26:18-19 — This verse provides reassurance about Israel's special status and divine purpose, which would be particularly comforting to someone facing illness or death. | Cf. Deuteronomy 29:29 — This verse acknowledges the limits of human understanding while emphasizing that following God's revealed commandments is what matters. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would help the sick person accept the mysteries of suffering while focusing on faithfulness to God's revealed will. | Cf. Zohar — In Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, these verses would be understood as invoking divine protection through their recitation, with each divine attribute mentioned (great, mighty, awesome) corresponding to specific sefirot or divine emanations that could provide spiritual healing.

[ii] The verb נָחַת (nichat) indicates being subdued or humbled, conveying reverential awe rather than simple fear.

[iii] This imagery of feet like hinds' feet (female deer) represents sure-footedness in difficult terrain, a metaphor for divine assistance in overcoming obstacles.

[iv] This phrase echoes the superscriptions of many psalms, suggesting this collection of prophetic verses was intended for musical performance.

יְהוָה בְּקִרְבֵּךְ לֹא תִירְאִי רָע
עוֹד: יְהוָה אֱלֹהַיִךְ בְּקִרְבֵּךְ
גִּבּוֹר יוֹשִׁיעַ יָשִׂישׂ עָלַיִךְ בְּשִׂמְחָה
יַחֲרִישׁ[i] בְּאַהֲבָתוֹ יָגִיל עָלַיִךְ
בְּרִנָּה: וְעָרְבָה לַיהוָה מִנְחַת
יְהוּדָה וִירוּשָׁלָם כִּימֵי עוֹלָם
וּכְשָׁנִים קַדְמֹנִיּוֹת: וְזָרְחָה לָכֶם
יִרְאֵי שְׁמִי שֶׁמֶשׁ צְדָקָה וּמַרְפֵּא
בִּכְנָפֶיהָ וִיצָאתֶם וּפִשְׁתֶּם כְּעֶגְלֵי
מַרְבֵּק:[ii] טוֹב יְהוָה לְמָעוֹז בְּיוֹם
צָרָה וְיֹדֵעַ חֹסֵי בוֹ: יְהוָה שָׁמַעְתִּי
שִׁמְעֲךָ יָרֵאתִי יְהוָה פָּעָלְךָ בְּקֶרֶב
שָׁנִים חַיֵּיהוּ בְּקֶרֶב שָׁנִים תּוֹדִיעַ
בְּרֹגֶז רַחֵם תִּזְכּוֹר:[iii] וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ
לִי לְעוֹלָם וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בְּצֶדֶק
וּבְמִשְׁפָּט וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים:
וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךָ לִי בֶּאֱמוּנָה וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת
יְהוָה: וְהָיָה אוֹתָם וּנְתַתִּים
וְהִרְבֵּיתִי אוֹתָם וְנָתַתִּי אֶת מִקְדָּשִׁי
בְּתוֹכָם לְעוֹלָם:[iv]

has removed your judgments;[1] He has cleared away your enemy. The King of Israel, the LORD, is in your midst; you will fear disaster no more. The LORD your God is in your midst, a mighty one who will save; He will rejoice over you with gladness; He will quiet you with His love;[A] He will exult over you with loud singing. Then the offering of Judah and Jerusalem will be pleasing to the LORD as in the days of old and as in former years. But for you who fear My name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings,[2] and you shall go forth and grow fat like calves from the stall.[B] The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble, and He knows those who take refuge in Him. O LORD, I have heard the report of You, and I fear; O LORD, revive Your work in the midst of the years, in the midst of the years make it known; in wrath remember mercy.[3] And I will betroth you to Me forever;[4] I will betroth you to Me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy. And

[A] Or: "He will be silent in His love" — The verb יַחֲרִישׁ (yacharish) literally means 'he will be silent/quiet.' The current translation interprets this as God quieting the person, but it could also mean God Himself being silent in contemplative love, which creates a more striking contrast with the exultation that follows.

[B] Or: "and you shall go forth and frisk about like calves from the stall" — The Hebrew וּפִשְׁתֶּם (u'fishtem) can indicate either growing fat (prosperity) or frisking/gamboling (joyful movement). In the context of healing and release, the image of playful, energetic movement might be more appropriate than simply growing fat.

[1] This and the following verses from Zephaniah 3:15-17 speak of divine consolation after punishment, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context would provide comfort to the sick or dying by assuring them that divine judgment will ultimately give way to mercy.

[2] This beautiful image from Malachi 4:2 of divine healing through the metaphor of sunrise would be particularly powerful in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and approaching death, offering hope of spiritual healing even when physical recovery might not be possible.

[3] This verse from Habakkuk 3:2 captures a central theological theme throughout Ma'avar Yabok: the hope that divine mercy will temper judgment, particularly relevant for those facing illness or death who might fear divine punishment.

[4] These verses from Hosea 2:19-20 use marriage imagery to describe God's relationship with Israel. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this metaphor extends to the individual soul's eternal bond with God that transcends death.

[i] The verb יַחֲרִישׁ (yacharish) literally means "He will be silent/quiet," creating a beautiful contrast with the exultation and singing that follows—divine love expressed through both peaceful silence and joyful noise.

[ii] The Hebrew וּפִשְׁתֶּם (u'fishtem) comes from the root פוּשׁ meaning "to grow fat" or "to spring about," conveying both prosperity and joyful vigor like well-fed calves.

[iii] This poignant juxtaposition of divine wrath (רֹגֶז/rogez) and mercy (רַחֵם/rachem) is characteristic of prophetic literature, expressing the tension between judgment and compassion in God's relationship with Israel.

[iv] Cf. Malachi 2:5-7 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse about God's covenant of life and peace with the priesthood takes on new significance in the context of death rituals, suggesting that proper spiritual service creates a covenant relationship that extends beyond death. | Cf. Habakkuk 3:19 — This verse about God making one's feet like hinds' feet (sure-footed even in difficult terrain) serves

I will make with them a covenant of peace, an everlasting covenant; it shall be with them, and I will give to them and multiply them, and I will set My sanctuary in their midst forever.[1] 1840R

(כתובים) קוֹלִי אֶל אֱלֹהִים
וְאֶצְעָקָה[i] קוֹלִי אֶל אֱלֹהִים
וְהַאֲזִין אֵלָי: זָכְרֵנִי יְהוָה בִּרְצוֹן 1705
עַמֶּךָ[ii] פָּקְדֵנִי בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ: לִרְאוֹת
בְּטוּבַ בְּחִירֶיךָ[iii] הוֹשִׁיעָה
בִּימִינְךָ וַעֲנֵנִי: עָזְרֵנִי יְהוָה אֱלֹהָי
הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי כְחַסְדֶּךָ: כִּי יַעֲמֹד לִימִין
אֶבְיוֹן לְהוֹשִׁיעַ מִשֹּׁפְטֵי נַפְשׁוֹ: 1710
יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּטַח בַּיהוָה עֶזְרָם וּמָגִנָּם
הוּא:[iv] יִרְאֵי יְהוָה בִּטְחוּ בַיהוָה
עֶזְרָם וּמָגִנָּם הוּא: יְהוָה זְכָרָנוּ
יְבָרֵךְ יְבָרֵךְ אֶת בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל יְבָרֵךְ
אֶת בֵּית אַהֲרֹן: וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ 1715
יָהּ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ:
יְהִי נָא חַסְדְּךָ לְנַחֲמֵנִי[v] כְּאִמְרָתְךָ
לְעַבְדֶּךָ: זֹאת נֶחָמָתִי בְעָנְיִי כִּי
אִמְרָתְךָ חִיָּתְנִי: סָמְכֵנִי כְאִמְרָתֶךָ

My voice calls to God and I cry out;[2] my voice calls to God and He listens to me. Remember me, O LORD, with favor for Your people; attend to me with Your salvation. That Your beloved ones may be delivered,[A] save with Your right hand and answer me. Help me, LORD my God; save me according to Your loving-kindness. For He stands at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who judge his soul. O Israel, trust in the LORD; He is their help and their shield. You who fear the LORD, trust in the LORD; He is their help and their shield. The LORD has remembered us; He will bless—He will bless the house of Israel; He will bless the house of Aaron. We will bless the LORD from this time forth and forever.[3] Hallelujah. May Your loving-kindness console me, according to Your word to Your servant. This is my comfort in my affliction, for Your word 1845R 1850R 1855R 1860R

[A] Or: "So that Your cherished ones may be rescued" — The Hebrew term 'yedidecha' carries connotations of deep affection beyond mere 'beloved,' while 'yechaltzun' can also convey the sense of being drawn out of danger. This alternative captures a slightly different emotional tone while preserving the meaning.

[1] This concluding verse from Ezekiel 37:26-27 refers to the restoration of Israel and the eternal presence of God's sanctuary. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it offers the ultimate consolation that beyond death lies eternal dwelling in God's presence.

[2] This prayer compilation opens with an expression of desperate calling to God, setting the tone for a supplication made in distress.

[3] Despite the prayer's context of suffering, it includes expressions of praise and blessing, balancing supplication with affirmation of God's worthiness of praise.

as a powerful metaphor for divine support during the challenging spiritual journey of illness and approaching death. | Cf. Malachi 4:2 — The imagery of the 'sun of righteousness' with 'healing in its wings' provides a powerful meditation for the sick and dying on divine healing that may transcend physical recovery to encompass spiritual restoration. | Cf. Psalm superscriptions — This phrase echoes the superscriptions of many psalms, suggesting this collection of prophetic verses was intended for musical performance, connecting these prophetic texts to liturgical practice similar to the psalms used elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok.

[i] This opening verse is from Psalm 77:2, beginning a collection of biblical verses arranged as a prayer seeking divine help in times of distress.

[ii] From Psalm 106:4, this verse is part of a prayer requesting to be included in God's salvation of His people.

[iii] From Psalm 60:7, this phrase appears as a standard opening formula for the concluding section of each prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok.

[iv] From Psalm 115:9-13, this section contains several consecutive verses that emphasize trust in God as a shield and source of blessing.

[v] This verse and the following three verses are from Psalm 119 (verses 76, 50, 116, and 122), forming a sequence focused on divine comfort and support in affliction.

וְאֶחְיֶה וְאַל תְּבִישֵׁנִי מִשִּׂבְרִי׃
עָרֵב עַבְדְּךָ לְטוֹב אַל יַעֲשְׁקֻנִי
זֵדִים׃ קוֹלִי שִׁמְעָה כְחַסְדֶּךָ[i] יְהוָה
כְּמִשְׁפָּטֶךָ חַיֵּנִי׃ תְּחִי נַפְשִׁי
וּתְהַלְלֶךָּ וּמִשְׁפָּטְךָ יַעְזְרֵנִי׃ סוֹמֵךְ
יְהוָה לְכָל הַנֹּפְלִים[ii] וְזוֹקֵף
לְכָל הַכְּפוּפִים׃ יְהוָה פֹּקֵחַ
עִוְרִים[iii] יְהוָה זוֹקֵף כְּפוּפִים יְהוָה
אֹהֵב צַדִּיקִים׃ הָרֹפֵא לִשְׁבוּרֵי
לֵב[iv] וּמְחַבֵּשׁ לְעַצְּבוֹתָם׃ בָּרוּךְ
יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל[v] מִן הָעוֹלָם
וְעַד הָעוֹלָם וְאָמַר כָּל הָעָם אָמֵן
הַלְלוּיָהּ׃ [vi]

has revived me.[1] Sustain me according to Your word, that I may live; and do not let me be ashamed of my hope. Be a guarantor for Your servant for good;[A] let not the arrogant oppress me. Hear my voice according to Your loving-kindness, O LORD; revive me according to Your justice. Let my soul live and it shall praise You, and let Your ordinances help me. The LORD supports all who fall and raises up all who are bowed down.[2] The LORD opens the eyes of the blind; the LORD raises those who are bowed down; the LORD loves the righteous. He heals the broken-hearted and binds up their wounds.[3] Blessed be the LORD God of Israel from everlasting to everlasting. And let all the people say, "Amen." Hallelujah. 1865R 1870R

ואח״כ יאמר למען יחלצון
ידידיך וגו׳ רפאני ה׳ וגו׳
ככל הכתוב למעלה עד צורי
וגואלי׳: עוד מזמור קכ״ח
וק״ל וקל״ד וקל״ח וקל״ט וק״מ

And afterward he shall say "That Your beloved ones may be delivered, etc."[4] "Heal me, O LORD, etc." following all that is written above until "my Rock and my Redeemer."[5] Additionally, Psalms 128, 130, 134, 138, 139, 140, 141, 142, 143, 148, 149, and 150 1875R

[A] Or: "Pledge Yourself as surety for Your servant's welfare" — The term 'arov' involves the concept of pledging or exchanging as a guarantee, similar to a financial transaction. This alternative emphasizes the covenantal aspect of God acting as a guarantor for the petitioner.

[1] The prayer highlights the therapeutic value of divine scripture itself as a source of comfort during suffering, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on reciting sacred texts during illness.
[2] This metaphor of God raising the fallen would be particularly meaningful in the context of illness, where the sick person is often physically bent or bedridden.
[3] The prayer concludes its petitionary section with an affirmation of God as healer, both of physical and emotional suffering, before transitioning to the final doxology.
[4] This is the beginning of a standard prayer formula that appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences. The 'etc.' (וגו׳) indicates that the full prayer would be known to the user and didn't need to be written out completely.
[5] This phrase (צורי וגואלי) marks the standard conclusion of the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, creating a consistent liturgical framework.

[i] From Psalm 119:149-150, continuing the theme of seeking divine attention and revival.
[ii] From Psalm 145:14-15, describing God as one who raises the fallen and straightens those who are bent down, a metaphor particularly relevant for the sick.
[iii] From Psalm 146:8, describing God's power to heal various afflictions, a theme of particular relevance in the context of prayers for the sick.
[iv] From Psalm 147:3, emphasizing God's role as a healer, particularly of emotional and spiritual wounds.
[v] From 1 Chronicles 16:36, a standard doxology (praise formula) that serves as a conclusion to this prayer compilation.
[vi] Cf. Psalm 77 — This opening verse sets the tone of crying out to God in distress, appropriate for someone experiencing serious illness or approaching death. | Cf. Psalm 119 — These verses are selected for their emphasis on divine comfort, sustenance, and revival through God's word, offering solace to the ill person through scriptural promises. | Cf. Psalm 145-147 — These verses emphasize God's role as healer and supporter of the weak, providing reassurance to the sick person that God specializes in helping those in physical distress. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's prayer structure — This compilation follows the therapeutic pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok: beginning with cries of distress, moving through petitions for help, and concluding with affirmations of God's healing power and praises of His name.

וקמ״א וקמ״ב וקמ״ג וקמ״ח
וקמ״ט וק״נ הם ראויים לבקשת
רחמים בפי כוונת השמנה
סדרים אלו[i] והבורר יברור
לעצמו[ii] ויוסיף או יגרע כפי
חכמתו כי הלכות קבועות לא
נתנו כאן:[iii]

are appropriate for seeking mercy according to the intention of these eight orders,[1] and one who selects may choose for himself and add or subtract according to his wisdom,[2] for fixed laws have not been given here. 1880R

(תהלים קכח) שִׁיר הַמַּעֲלוֹת[iv] אַשְׁרֵי
כָּל־יְרֵא יְיָ הַהֹלֵךְ בִּדְרָכָיו: יְגִיעַ
כַּפֶּיךָ כִּי תֹאכֵל[v] אַשְׁרֶיךָ וְטוֹב
לָךְ: אֶשְׁתְּךָ כְּגֶפֶן פֹּרִיָּה[vi]
בְּיַרְכְּתֵי בֵיתֶךָ בָּנֶיךָ כִּשְׁתִלֵי זֵיתִים[vii]
סָבִיב

(Psalm 128) A Song of Ascents.[A] Happy is everyone who fears the LORD, who walks in His ways. When you eat the labor of your hands,[B] you shall be happy, and it shall be well with you. Your wife shall be like a fruitful vine[3] within the recesses of your house;[C] your 1885R

[A] Or: "A Pilgrim Song" — This translation captures the practical function of these psalms as songs sung by pilgrims traveling to Jerusalem for festivals, making their purpose more immediately clear to modern readers unfamiliar with Temple practices.

[B] Or: "When you enjoy the fruit of your labor" — This translation preserves the meaning while using more natural English phrasing. The Hebrew uses the metaphor of 'eating' one's labor to represent enjoying the benefits of one's work.

[C] Or: "in the inner chambers of your home" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the spatial concept of the private, interior portions of the home where the wife would typically manage household affairs in ancient Near Eastern culture.

[1] The text confirms that Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section contains eight distinct liturgical sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying, each with a similar structure but offering different psalm options.

[2] This instruction reflects the text's balance between providing structured guidance and allowing for adaptation to individual circumstances. Rather than rigid prescription, Ma'avar Yabok offers a flexible framework that can be tailored based on the situation and the wisdom of those attending to the sick.

[3] The imagery of fertility and abundance (wife as vine, children as olive plants) creates a picture of domestic harmony and divine blessing. These agricultural metaphors would be particularly poignant for those concerned about their family's future wellbeing during serious illness.

[i] The text refers to 'these eight orders' (השמנה סדרים אלו), confirming that the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok contains eight distinct liturgical sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying.

[ii] This phrase indicates flexibility in the prayer selection process, suggesting that while Ma'avar Yabok provides structured guidance, it allows for personal discretion based on individual circumstances.

[iii] The author explicitly states that these prayer recommendations are not fixed law (הלכות קבועות), distinguishing them from obligatory ritual requirements and emphasizing the discretionary nature of these prayers for the sick.

[iv] "Song of Ascents" refers to a collection of fifteen psalms (Psalms 120-134) that were likely sung by pilgrims as they ascended to Jerusalem for the three annual festivals, or by the Levites as they ascended the fifteen steps of the Temple. In Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm appears in a section of prayers recommended for recitation by or for the sick.

[v] This phrase emphasizes the value of honest labor and self-sufficiency. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would have special significance for the ill person who might be concerned about dependency or inability to support their family.

[vi] The comparison of a wife to a "fruitful vine" employs botanical imagery that continues with the children compared to "olive plants." In kabbalistic thought, these images relate to fertility, continuity, and divine blessing. The vine particularly symbolizes abundance and joy.

[vii] Olive plants represent vitality, longevity, and continuity, as olive trees are known for their long life and productivity. In the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this imagery of thriving children would offer hope and comfort regarding family continuity even in the face of illness.

1750 לְשֻׁלְחָנֶךָ׃ הִנֵּה כִי־כֵן יְבֹרַךְ
גָּבֶר יְרֵא יְיָ׃ יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ מִצִּיּוֹן
וּרְאֵה בְּטוּב יְרוּשָׁלָם כֹּל יְמֵי
חַיֶּיךָ׃ וּרְאֵה־בָנִים לְבָנֶיךָ שָׁלוֹם
[ii] עַל־יִשְׂרָאֵל׃[i]

children like olive plants around your table. Behold, thus shall the man be blessed who fears the LORD. May the LORD bless you from Zion,[1] and may you see the good of Jerusalem all the days of your life. And may you see children of your children.[A] Peace be upon Israel.[2] 1890R 1895R

1755 שִׁיר הַמַּעֲלוֹת (תהלים קל)
מִמַּעֲמַקִּים קְרָאתִיךָ יְיָ׃[iii] אֲדֹנָי
שִׁמְעָה בְקוֹלִי תִּהְיֶינָה אָזְנֶיךָ
קַשֻּׁבוֹת לְקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי׃ אִם־עֲוֹנוֹת
[iv] תִּשְׁמָר־יָהּ אֲדֹנָי מִי יַעֲמֹד׃ 1900R
1760 כִּי־עִמְּךָ הַסְלִיחָה לְמַעַן תִּוָּרֵא׃
קִוִּיתִי יְיָ קִוְּתָה נַפְשִׁי וְלִדְבָרוֹ
הוֹחָלְתִּי׃ נַפְשִׁי לַאדֹנָי מִשֹּׁמְרִים

(Psalm 130) A Song of Ascents. Out of the depths I have called to You,[3] O LORD. Lord, hear my voice; let Your ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications. If You, LORD, should mark iniquities,[4] O Lord, who could stand? But with You there is forgiveness, that You may be feared. I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and in His word I hope. My soul waits for the Lord more than those who watch

[A] Or: "And may you live to see your grandchildren" — While the original translation is literally accurate, this alternate more naturally expresses the intended blessing of longevity and family continuity in contemporary English, making the meaning immediately clear to modern readers.

[1] The mention of Zion (Jerusalem) connects personal blessing with the sacred center of Jewish religious life. In the context of prayers for healing, this links individual recovery with divine presence emanating from the holy city.

[2] The psalm's conclusion widens its focus from individual blessing to national welfare, reflecting the Jewish theological understanding that personal and communal wellbeing are interconnected. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on the relationship between individual spiritual health and communal responsibility.

[3] This psalm is one of the most profound expressions of penitence and hope in the Psalter, often recited in times of distress and as part of mourning rituals.

[4] The psalm moves from the personal to the universal here, suggesting that no one could withstand divine judgment if God were to account for all transgressions.

[i] This concluding blessing for peace over Israel extends the psalm's focus from individual blessing to communal welfare. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this connects the individual's healing with the well-being of the entire community, a theme consistent with the book's emphasis on communal responsibility in times of illness and death.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 127 — Psalm 128 continues the themes of its predecessor, expanding on the concept that children are a divine blessing. While Psalm 127 states that "children are a heritage from the LORD," Psalm 128 elaborates by depicting them as olive plants around the table, emphasizing both abundance and stability. | Cf. Proverbs 31:10-31 — The image of the wife as a "fruitful vine within the recesses of your house" echoes Proverbs 31's portrait of the industrious wife whose value is recognized within the domestic sphere. Both texts honor the woman's contribution to family prosperity while acknowledging the gendered division of space (women in the "inner" parts of the house) typical of ancient Near Eastern societies. | Cf. Psalm 134 — Both Psalm 128 and Psalm 134 conclude the Songs of Ascents with blessing formulas. Psalm 128's "May the LORD bless you from Zion" is echoed in Psalm 134's "May the LORD, maker of heaven and earth, bless you from Zion." This suggests a liturgical function for these blessings, possibly used by priests or Levites to bless pilgrims or worshippers. | Cf. Ezekiel 19:10 — The image of the wife as a "fruitful vine" echoes biblical metaphors where vines represent fertility and abundance. In Ezekiel, Israel is "like a vine in your bloodline, planted by the waters, fruitful and full of branches." This suggests that the domestic blessing in Psalm 128 mirrors the national blessing of Israel, connecting household prosperity with national flourishing.

[iii] The Hebrew 'ma'amakim' (depths) conveys both physical depth and emotional/spiritual profundity, suggesting a cry from the deepest part of one's being in a state of extreme distress.

[iv] The verb 'tishmor' (mark/keep) suggests the idea of God keeping a record or account of sins, like a creditor tracking debts.

לַבֹּקֶר שֹׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר[i]: יַחֵל
יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶל־יְיָ כִּי־עִם־יְיָ הַחֶסֶד
וְהַרְבֵּה עִמּוֹ פְּדוּת: וְהוּא יִפְדֶּה
אֶת־יִשְׂרָאֵל מִכֹּל עֲוֹנֹתָיו: [ii]

for the morning[1]—yes, more than those who watch for the morning. Let Israel hope in the LORD, for with the LORD there is mercy, and with Him is abundant redemption. And He will redeem Israel from all his iniquities.[2]

1905R

1765

(תהלים קלד) שִׁיר הַמַּעֲלוֹת[iii] הִנֵּה
בָרְכוּ אֶת־יְיָ כָּל־עַבְדֵי יְיָ הָעֹמְדִים
בְּבֵית־יְיָ בַּלֵּילוֹת: [iv] שְׂאוּ־יְדֵכֶם
קֹדֶשׁ [v] וּבָרְכוּ אֶת־יְיָ: יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ
מִצִּיּוֹן [vi] עֹשֵׂה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ: [vii]

A Song of Ascents.[3] Behold, bless the LORD, all servants of the LORD who stand in the house of the LORD at night.[A] Lift up your hands in holiness[4] and bless the LORD. May the LORD bless you from Zion,[5] He who made heaven and earth.

1910R

1770

[A] Or: "who serve in the house of the LORD during the night watches" — The Hebrew עֹמְדִים (standing) often carries the connotation of service or duty in religious contexts, and 'during the night watches' more clearly conveys the ongoing nature of the service being performed. This alternate translation might better capture the sense of dedicated vigilance that would resonate with Ma'avar Yabok's context of caring for the dying.

[1] This comparison to watchmen waiting for dawn would resonate deeply in ancient times when night brought heightened dangers and vulnerability, making morning an eagerly anticipated relief.
[2] The psalm concludes by expanding from individual to communal salvation, expressing confidence that divine redemption extends to the entire community of Israel.
[3] The Hebrew phrase שִׁיר הַמַּעֲלוֹת (Shir HaMa'alot) literally means "Song of the Steps/Ascents." It appears in 15 psalms (120-134), possibly referring to the 15 steps of the Temple, pilgrimages to Jerusalem, or a musical notation.
[4] The raising of hands (נְשִׂיאַת כַּפַּיִם) is a traditional prayer gesture in Judaism. Its inclusion in this psalm, which appears in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgy for the sick, suggests that those attending to the dying should pray with both physical gestures and spiritual intention.
[5] The psalm contains a beautiful symmetry: it begins with humans blessing God and concludes

[i] This repetition creates a powerful poetic emphasis, comparing the soul's longing for God to watchmen eagerly awaiting the dawn after a dangerous night watch.
[ii] Cf. Lamentations 3:55-57 — This connection reinforces that the 'depths' in Psalm 130 can refer to profound suffering or despair, similar to the pit imagery in Lamentations, while maintaining hope in divine response. | Cf. Jonah 2:2-3 — This parallel reinforces the understanding of 'depths' as a place of profound crisis where divine intervention is urgently needed, suggesting the psalm could be understood as a prayer from someone in an extremely desperate spiritual or physical situation. | Cf. Psalms 143:2 — Both texts express the theological understanding that human righteousness cannot withstand divine scrutiny, establishing the need for divine mercy rather than strict justice.
[iii] This is the title of Psalm 134, the last of fifteen psalms (120-134) bearing this designation. "Song of Ascents" may refer to pilgrimages to Jerusalem, steps of the Temple, or a style of musical performance.
[iv] This likely refers to the Levites who served night watches in the Temple. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this might be understood as referring to those who keep vigil with the sick or dying during nighttime hours.
[v] The raising of hands is a traditional Jewish prayer gesture. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this might symbolize the spiritual elevation sought for the soul of the sick or dying person.
[vi] This final verse shifts from addressing the servants to blessing them, creating a call-and-response structure. In Ma'avar Yabok, this may represent the reciprocal relationship between those performing sacred duties for the sick/dying and the divine blessing they receive in return.
[vii] Cf. Psalm 121:2 — By echoing the language of Psalm 121, this psalm connects care for the dying with divine protection. Just as God who "made heaven and earth" protects Israel in Psalm 121, here that same Creator blesses those who maintain sacred night vigils. | Cf. 1 Chronicles 9:33 — The psalm's reference to those "who stand in the house of the LORD at night" likely alludes to the Levites who maintained continual service in the Temple. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would resonate with the sacred duty of maintaining vigil with the dying, suggesting that this too is a holy service comparable to Temple worship. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 14b — The rabbinic

לְדָוִד אוֹדְךָ (תהלים קלח)
בְּכָל־לִבִּי נֶגֶד אֱלֹהִים[i] אֲזַמְּרֶךָּ׃
אֶשְׁתַּחֲוֶה אֶל־הֵיכַל קָדְשֶׁךָ וְאוֹדֶה
אֶת־שִׁמְךָ עַל־חַסְדְּךָ וְעַל־אֲמִתֶּךָ
כִּי־הִגְדַּלְתָּ עַל־כָּל־שִׁמְךָ
אִמְרָתֶךָ[ii]׃ בְּיוֹם קָרָאתִי וַתַּעֲנֵנִי
תַּרְהִבֵנִי בְנַפְשִׁי עֹז[iii]׃ יוֹדוּךָ
יְיָ כָּל־מַלְכֵי־אֶרֶץ כִּי שָׁמְעוּ
אִמְרֵי־פִיךָ׃ וְיָשִׁירוּ בִּדְרָכֵי יְיָ
כִּי־גָדוֹל כְּבוֹד יְיָ׃ כִּי־רָם יְיָ
וְשָׁפָל יִרְאֶה וְגָבֹהַּ מִמֶּרְחָק יְיֵדָע׃
אִם־אֵלֵךְ בְּקֶרֶב צָרָה תְּחַיֵּנִי עַל
אַף אֹיְבַי תִּשְׁלַח יָדֶךָ וְתוֹשִׁיעֵנִי
יְמִינֶךָ׃ יְיָ יִגְמֹר בַּעֲדִי יְיָ חַסְדְּךָ
לְעוֹלָם מַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ אַל־תֶּרֶף׃ [iv]

Of David. I will praise You with my whole heart; before the divine beings[A B] I will sing praises to You. I will bow down toward Your holy temple and give thanks to Your name for Your loving kindness and for Your truth, for You have magnified Your word above all Your name. On the day I called, You answered me; You strengthened me with courage in my soul. All the kings of the earth shall praise You, O LORD, when they hear the words of Your mouth. And they shall sing of the ways of the LORD, for great is the glory of the LORD. Though the LORD is exalted, yet He regards the lowly, but the haughty He knows from afar. If I walk in the midst of trouble, You will revive me; You will stretch out Your hand against the wrath of my enemies, and Your right hand will save me.[1] The LORD will fulfill His purpose for me;[2] Your loving kindness, O LORD, endures forever; do not forsake the works of Your hands.

לַמְנַצֵּחַ לְדָוִד (תהלים קלט)

(Psalm 139) For the conductor. A psalm of David.

[A] Or: "before the gods" — Some scholars interpret 'elohim' here as referring to pagan gods, with the psalmist declaring that he will praise the true God in defiance of false deities. This reading is grammatically possible but less likely in the theological context of the psalm.

[B] Or: "in the presence of rulers/judges" — The term 'elohim' is occasionally used in the Hebrew Bible to refer to human authorities or judges. This interpretation would suggest the psalmist is making a public declaration of praise before human authorities.

with God blessing humans. This reciprocity would be meaningful in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, suggesting that those who perform the sacred duty of attending to the dying will themselves receive divine blessing.

[1] The imagery of God's 'right hand' appears frequently in psalms as a symbol of divine power and intervention. In the context of this psalm about divine protection, it represents God's active saving power.

[2] The Hebrew יִגְמֹר בַּעֲדִי literally means 'will complete/perfect concerning me' and refers to God bringing to completion what He has started in the psalmist's life.

tradition extensively discussed the practice of raising hands in prayer, mentioned in this psalm. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would suggest that physical prayer gestures are important components of the liturgical care for the dying, combining bodily actions with spiritual intentions.

[i] The phrase can be translated as 'before the gods' or 'before the divine beings.' In the context of this psalm, it likely refers to either angelic beings or judges who were sometimes called 'elohim' in biblical Hebrew.

[ii] This phrase is difficult to translate precisely. It literally means 'for You have magnified above all Your name Your word.' It suggests that God places the fulfillment of His promises (His word) even above His reputation (His name).

[iii] This unusual Hebrew phrase literally means 'You made me proud/bold in my soul with strength.' It describes divine empowerment that creates inner courage or confidence.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 23:6 — Both texts express confidence in God's ongoing kindness (חֶסֶד) that persists throughout the psalmist's life. Psalm 138 expands this to an eternal timeframe ('לְעוֹלָם') while maintaining the personal relationship between the individual and the divine. | Cf. Isaiah 57:15 — Psalm 138:6 and Isaiah 57:15 share the theological concept that God, despite His exalted nature, pays special attention to the lowly/humble. This paradox of divine transcendence combined with immanent care for the vulnerable is a recurring theme in biblical literature.

מִזְמוֹר יְיָ חְקַרְתַּנִי וַתֵּדָע: אַתָּה
יָדַעְתָּ שִׁבְתִּי וְקוּמִי בַּנְתָּה לְרֵעִי
1790 מֵרָחוֹק: אָרְחִי וְרִבְעִי זֵרִיתָ
וְכָל־דְּרָכַי הִסְכַּנְתָּה: כִּי אֵין
מִלָּה בִּלְשׁוֹנִי הֵן יְיָ יָדַעְתָּ כֻלָּהּ:
אָחוֹר וָקֶדֶם צַרְתָּנִי וַתָּשֶׁת עָלַי
כַּפֶּכָה: (פלאיה) [פְּלִיאָה][i] דַּעַת
1795 מִמֶּנִּי נִשְׂגְּבָה לֹא־אוּכַל לָהּ: אָנָה
אֵלֵךְ מֵרוּחֶךָ וְאָנָה מִפָּנֶיךָ אֶבְרָח:
אִם־אֶסַּק שָׁמַיִם שָׁם אָתָּה וְאַצִּיעָה
שְׁאוֹל הִנֶּךָּ: אֶשָּׂא כַנְפֵי־שָׁחַר
אֶשְׁכְּנָה בְּאַחֲרִית יָם: גַּם־שָׁם
1800 יָדְךָ תַנְחֵנִי וְתֹאחֲזֵנִי יְמִינֶךָ:
וָאֹמַר אַךְ־חֹשֶׁךְ יְשׁוּפֵנִי וְלַיְלָה
אוֹר בַּעֲדֵנִי: גַּם־חֹשֶׁךְ לֹא־יַחְשִׁיךְ
מִמֶּךָּ[ii] וְלַיְלָה כַּיּוֹם יָאִיר כַּחֲשֵׁיכָה
כָּאוֹרָהּ: כִּי־אַתָּה קָנִיתָ כִלְיֹתָי
1805 תְּסָכְּנֵנִי בְּבֶטֶן אִמִּי: אוֹדְךָ עַל כִּי
נוֹרָאוֹת נִפְלֵיתִי נִפְלָאִים מַעֲשֶׂיךָ
וְנַפְשִׁי יֹדַעַת מְאֹד: לֹא־נִכְחַד
עָצְמִי מִמְּךָ אֲשֶׁר־עָשִׂיתִי בַסֵּתֶר
רֻקַּמְתִּי בְּתַחְתִּיּוֹת אָרֶץ: גָּלְמִי
1810 רָאוּ עֵינֶיךָ וְעַל־סִפְרְךָ כֻּלָּם
יִכָּתֵבוּ יָמִים יֻצָּרוּ (ולא) [וְלוֹ]
אֶחָד בָּהֶ[iii]ם: וְלִי מַה־יָּקְרוּ

O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You
know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my 1935R
thought from afar.[A] You sift my path and my lying
down,[B] and are familiar with all my ways. For there
is not a word on my tongue that You, O LORD,
do not know completely. Behind and before, You
have formed me, and laid Your hand upon me. Such 1940R
knowledge is too wondrous for me; it is exalted, I
cannot attain it. Where can I go from Your spirit?
Where can I flee from Your presence? If I ascend
to heaven, You are there, and if I make my bed in
Sheol, behold, You are there.[1] If I take the wings 1945R
of dawn and dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea,
even there Your hand will guide me, and Your right
hand will hold me. If I say, "Surely darkness will
engulf me, and the light around me will be night,"
even darkness is not dark to You, and night shines 1950R
as the day; darkness and light are alike to You. For
You formed my inward parts; You covered me in my
mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and
wonderfully made; wondrous are Your works, and
my soul knows it well. My frame was not hidden 1955R
from You when I was made in secret, when I was
woven together in the depths of the earth.[2] Your
eyes saw my unformed substance,[C] and in Your book

[A] Or: "You discern my intentions from afar" — The term 'לְרֵעִי' has been variously translated, with some interpreting it as 'my thought' and others as 'my intention' or 'my purpose.' The alternate translation preserves the meaning while using terminology that might be clearer in context.

[B] Or: "You winnow my going out and my lying down" — The Hebrew verb 'זֵרִיתָ' (zerita) comes from the root meaning 'to winnow/sift/scatter.' The alternate uses 'winnow' which more directly connects to the agricultural metaphor in the original Hebrew while 'going out' for 'אָרְחִי' (orchi) provides a clearer parallel to 'lying down.'

[C] Or: "Your eyes beheld my embryo" — The Hebrew term 'גָּלְמִי' (golmi) refers specifically to an unformed or embryonic state. While 'unformed substance' captures the meaning, 'embryo' is more direct and precise in modern English, especially in a psalm discussing human formation.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse would take on special significance for those facing death, offering reassurance that divine presence continues even in Sheol (the realm of the dead). This theological point aligns with the book's purpose of providing spiritual comfort during the transition from life to death.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'בְּתַחְתִּיּוֹת אָרֶץ' (in the depths of the earth) uses imagery that appears elsewhere in Scripture to refer to the realm of the dead. Here, however, it functions as a poetic metaphor for the hidden, mysterious process of embryonic development, comparing the womb to the earth's depths where things form unseen.

[i] In the original text, this word appears as 'פלאיה' with a correction to 'פְּלִיאָה'. This scribal correction demonstrates careful attention to the text's accuracy.

[ii] This poetic phrase employs the rhetorical device of using the same Hebrew root (חשך/darkness) in different forms, creating a wordplay that emphasizes how darkness itself cannot create darkness from God's perspective.

[iii] The Hebrew text shows a scribal correction from 'ולא' (and not) to 'וְלוֹ' (and to him/it). This textual variant significantly affects the meaning, changing from 'not one of them existed' to 'though not one of them yet existed.'

רַעְיֶךָ אֵל מָה עָצְמוּ רָאשֵׁיהֶם:
אֶסְפְּרֵם מֵחוֹל יִרְבּוּן הֶקִיצוֹתִי
וְעוֹדִי עִמָּךְ: אִם־תִּקְטֹל אֱלוֹהַּ
רָשָׁע וְאַנְשֵׁי דָמִים סוּרוּ מֶנִּי:
אֲשֶׁר יֹמְרוּךָ לְמִזְמָה נָשׂוּא לַשָּׁוְא
עָרֶיךָ: הֲלוֹא־מְשַׂנְאֶיךָ יְיָ אֶשְׂנָא
וּבְתַקּוֹמְמֶיךָ אֶתְקוֹטָט: תַּכְלִית
שִׂנְאָה שְׂנֵאתִים [i] לְאוֹיְבִים הָיוּ לִי:
חָקְרֵנִי אֵל וְדַע לְבָבִי בְּחָנֵנִי וְדַע
שַׂרְעַפָּי: וּרְאֵה אִם־דֶּרֶךְ־עֹצֶב בִּי
וּנְחֵנִי בְּדֶרֶךְ עוֹלָם: [ii]

they were all written—the days that were formed, though not one of them existed.[A] How precious to me are Your thoughts, O God![1] How vast is the sum of them! If I should count them, they would outnumber the sand. I awake, and I am still with You. If only You would slay the wicked, O God—O men of bloodshed, depart from me—those who speak of You with evil intent, who take Your name in vain, Your enemies. Do I not hate those who hate You, O LORD? And do I not loathe those who rise up against You? I hate them with perfect hatred; they have become my enemies. Search me, O God, and know my heart; test me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any hurtful way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting.[2]

(תהלים קמ) לַמְנַצֵּחַ מִזְמוֹר
לְדָוִד: חַלְּצֵנִי יְיָ מֵאָדָם רָע
מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים תִּנְצְרֵנִי: אֲשֶׁר
חָשְׁבוּ רָעוֹת בְּלֵב כָּל־יוֹם יָגוּרוּ
מִלְחָמוֹת: שָׁנְנוּ לְשׁוֹנָם כְּמוֹ־נָחָשׁ
חֲמַת עַכְשׁוּב תַּחַת שִׂפְתֵימוֹ סֶלָה:
שָׁמְרֵנִי יְיָ מִידֵי רָשָׁע מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים

(Psalm 140) For the Chief Musician. A Psalm of David. Deliver me, O LORD, from evil men; preserve me from violent men,[B] who devise evil in their hearts;[3] all day long they stir up wars. They sharpen their tongues like a serpent; the venom of asps is under their lips.[4] Selah. Keep me, O LORD, from the hands of the wicked; preserve me from violent

[A] Or: "days were predetermined when none of them yet existed" — This difficult phrase has been variously interpreted. The alternate translation better conveys the concept of divine foreknowledge of all the days of one's life before they come into being, which fits the psalm's theme of God's complete knowledge of the individual.

[B] Or: "from men of violence" — While 'violent men' is accurate, 'men of violence' more clearly indicates that violence is their defining characteristic rather than merely a temporary state.

[1] The Hebrew term 'רַעְיֶךָ' (re'echa) has been variously translated as 'thoughts,' 'companions,' or 'friends.' The translation follows the contextual meaning of God's thoughts concerning the psalmist, which fits the psalm's emphasis on divine knowledge.

[2] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this concluding request would take on additional significance as a prayer for divine guidance through the ultimate transition of death into eternal life, connecting to the book's central metaphor of 'crossing over.'

[3] The Hebrew expresses continuous action—they are constantly plotting evil, not just occasionally.

[4] This powerful metaphor equates malicious speech with deadly poison, suggesting that harmful words can be as destructive as venom.

[i] The Hebrew employs an emphatic construction 'perfect hatred I hate them' that intensifies the emotional force through repetition of the same root.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 2:7 — The psalm expands on Genesis by depicting not just the initial creation but God's intimate involvement in the formation of each individual in the womb, suggesting that each person's creation is as intentional as Adam's. | Cf. Job 10:8-12 — Both texts use embodied language to describe divine creation of human life, but while Job's account expresses bewilderment that God would create him only to destroy him, Psalm 139 presents this intimate knowledge as comforting rather than troubling. | Cf. Jeremiah 1:5 — Psalm 139 develops this concept of divine foreknowledge from an individual perspective, detailing how God's knowledge encompasses not just prophetic calling but every aspect of human existence from conception through death. | Cf. Zohar III:47b — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this connection to Zoharic teaching would remind the sick or dying person that their life span is divinely ordained, with each day having spiritual purpose, which offers comfort when contemplating mortality.

תִּנְצְּרֵנִי אֲשֶׁר חָשְׁבוּ לְדַחוֹת
פְּעָמָי: טָמְנוּ־גֵאִים פַּח לִי וַחֲבָלִים
פָּרְשׂוּ רֶשֶׁת לְיַד־מַעְגָּל מֹקְשִׁים
שָׁתוּ־לִי סֶלָה: אָמַרְתִּי לַיהוָה אֵלִי
1835 אָתָּה הַאֲזִינָה יְיָ קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי:
יֱהוִה אֲדֹנָי עֹז יְשׁוּעָתִי סַכֹּתָה
לְרֹאשִׁי בְּיוֹם נָשֶׁק: אַל־תִּתֵּן יְיָ
מַאֲוֵי רָשָׁע זְמָמוֹ אַל־תָּפֵק יָרוּמוּ
סֶלָה: רֹאשׁ מְסִבָּי עְמַל שְׂפָתֵימוֹ
1840 (יכסומו) [יְכַסֵּימוֹ][i]: (ימיטו)
[יְמוֹטוּ] עֲלֵיהֶם גֶּחָלִים בָּאֵשׁ
יַפְּלֵם בְּמַהֲמֹרוֹת בַּל־יָקוּמוּ: אִישׁ
לָשׁוֹן בַּל־יִכּוֹן בָּאָרֶץ אִישׁ־חָמָס
רָע יְצוּדֶנּוּ לְמַדְחֵפוֹת: (ידעת)
1845 [יָדַעְתִּי] כִּי־יַעֲשֶׂה יְיָ דִּין עָנִי
מִשְׁפַּט אֶבְיוֹנִים: אַךְ צַדִּיקִים יוֹדוּ
לִשְׁמֶךָ יֵשְׁבוּ יְשָׁרִים אֶת־פָּנֶיךָ: [ii]

men who have planned to trip my feet. The proud have hidden a snare for me, and with cords they have spread a net; by the wayside they have set traps for me. Selah. I said to the LORD, "You are my God"; hear, O LORD, the voice of my supplications. O 1985R
LORD God, the strength of my salvation,[1] You have covered my head in the day of battle. Do not grant, O LORD, the desires of the wicked; do not further his evil plot, lest they be exalted. Selah. As for the head of those who surround me, let the trouble of 1990R
their own lips cover them.[A] Let burning coals fall upon them;[2] let them be cast into the fire, into deep pits,[B] that they rise not up again. Let not a slanderer be established in the earth; let evil hunt the violent man to overthrow him.[C] I know that the LORD will 1995R
maintain the cause of the afflicted,[3] and justice for the poor. Surely the righteous shall give thanks to Your name; the upright shall dwell in Your presence.

(תהלים קמא) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד[iii] יְיָ

(Psalm 141) A psalm of David. O LORD, I call upon

[A]Or: "overwhelm them" — The Hebrew verb 'yechaseimu' carries the sense of covering completely or overwhelming. While 'cover' is accurate, 'overwhelm' captures the intensity of the desired consequence for the wicked.

[B]Or: "into watery depths" — The Hebrew 'mahamorot' can refer specifically to watery pits or depths. While 'deep pits' is accurate, 'watery depths' captures a more specific aspect of the original term that carries connotations of drowning or overwhelming floods.

[C]Or: "into utter ruin" — The Hebrew 'lemadchefot' conveys the image of being pushed over precipices or into destruction. 'To overthrow him' captures the action but 'into utter ruin' better conveys the totality of the destruction intended in the psalm.

[1]This phrase combines military imagery with theological concepts of divine deliverance, portraying God as both the source and the power behind the psalmist's protection.

[2]The imagery of burning coals likely alludes to divine judgment, similar to other biblical passages where fire symbolizes God's purifying or punishing power.

[3]This statement shifts from personal petition to a broader theological affirmation about God's character as defender of the vulnerable, moving from the individual to the universal.

[i]The text contains Kethiv/Qere variants (written vs. read forms) indicated by the square brackets, showing corrections to the traditional text. This reflects the meticulous transmission process of biblical texts.

[ii]Cf. Psalm 58:4-5 — The psalmist draws on established imagery comparing dangerous speech to serpent venom. This connection suggests the author sees slanderous speech as not merely harmful but actively poisonous and potentially deadly. | Cf. Psalm 7:14-16 — Both psalms employ the principle of poetic justice where the weapons or traps of the wicked become instruments of their own destruction. This reflects the theological view that divine justice often works through allowing evildoers to be caught in their own devices. | Cf. Romans 3:13 — While this is a later reference (not contemporary with the psalm), it shows how this psalm became integrated into broader theological reflections on human wickedness, particularly focusing on harmful speech as a manifestation of sin. | Cf. Psalm 9:4 — This reflects a consistent theme in Davidic psalms: confidence that God acts as the defender of those who lack earthly power or protection. The poor and afflicted can rely on divine justice when human systems fail them.

[iii]This psalm is attributed to King David and appears in the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick. This context explains why it appears in a manual focused on end-of-life care.

קָרָאתִיךָ חוּשָׁה לִּי הַאֲזִינָה קוֹלִי
בְּקָרְאִי־לָךְ: תִּכּוֹן תְּפִלָּתִי קְטֹרֶת
לְפָנֶיךָ [i] מַשְׂאַת כַּפַּי מִנְחַת־עָרֶב:
שִׁיתָה יְיָ שָׁמְרָה לְפִי [ii] נִצְּרָה
עַל־דַּל שְׂפָתָי: אַל־תַּט־לִבִּי
לְדָבָר רָע לְהִתְעוֹלֵל עֲלִלוֹת
בְּרִשְׁעָה אֶת־אִישִׁים פֹּעֲלֵי־אָוֶן
וּבַל־אֶלְחַם בִּמַנְעַמֵּיהֶם: יֶהֱלְמֵנִי
צַדִּיק חֶסֶד וְיוֹכִיחֵנִי [iii] שֶׁמֶן רֹאשׁ
אַל־יָנִי רֹאשִׁי כִּי־עוֹד וּתְפִלָּתִי
בְּרָעוֹתֵיהֶם: נִשְׁמְטוּ בִידֵי־סֶלַע
שֹׁפְטֵיהֶם וְשָׁמְעוּ אֲמָרַי כִּי נָעֲמוּ:
כְּמוֹ פֹלֵחַ וּבֹקֵעַ בָּאָרֶץ נִפְזְרוּ
עַצְמֵינוּ לְפִי שְׁאוֹל [iv]: כִּי אֵלֶיךָ
יֱהוִה אֲדֹנָי עֵינָי בְּכָה חָסִיתִי
אַל־תְּעַר נַפְשִׁי: שָׁמְרֵנִי מִידֵי פַח
יָקְשׁוּ לִי [v] וּמוֹקְשׁוֹת פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן:

You; hasten to me. Give ear to my voice when I call to You. Let my prayer be established as incense before You,[1] the lifting of my hands as the evening offering. Set a guard, O LORD, over my mouth; keep watch over the door of my lips. Do not incline my heart to any evil thing, to practice wicked deeds with men who do iniquity; and let me not eat of their delicacies. Let the righteous strike me—it is a kindness;[A] let him rebuke me—it is oil on my head;[2] let my head not refuse it. For still my prayer is against their evil deeds. When their judges are thrown down among the rocks,[B] they will hear my words, for they are sweet. As when one plows and breaks up the earth, our bones are scattered at the mouth of Sheol.[3] But my eyes are toward You, O LORD, my Lord; in You I seek refuge, do not leave my soul defenseless.[4] Keep me from the snares they

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[A] Or: "Let the righteous one strike me with kindness" — The Hebrew phrase allows for interpreting 'chesed' (kindness) either as describing the nature of the striking itself or as an appositive explaining that the striking is an act of kindness. This alternate reading suggests the righteous person's correction is delivered with kindness rather than harshness.

[B] Or: "Their judges have been hurled down the sides of a cliff" — The challenging Hebrew phrase could refer to execution by throwing from heights, which was an ancient punishment. This alternate translation makes the violent image more explicit, which may better convey the psalm's contrast between the fate of the wicked and the psalmist's hope for divine protection.

[1] The Hebrew compares prayer to 'ketoret' (קְטֹרֶת), the special incense blend offered in the ancient Temple. This verse establishes a crucial concept in Jewish mystical thought that proper prayer serves as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings.

[2] The Hebrew 'shemen rosh' (שֶׁמֶן רֹאשׁ) literally means 'oil of the head' or 'finest oil.' This creates a metaphor where righteous criticism is compared to the anointing oil used for kings and priests—something precious and sanctifying rather than merely painful.

[3] Sheol (שְׁאוֹל) is the biblical term for the underworld or grave. This vivid imagery of scattered bones at death's entrance creates a stark contrast with the psalm's conclusion of divine protection, which would be particularly meaningful in a text focused on end-of-life care.

[4] The Hebrew 'al-t'ar nafshi' (אַל־תְּעַר נַפְשִׁי) literally means 'do not pour out my soul,' a metaphor for making one vulnerable or defenseless. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would connect to the concern for protecting the soul during the vulnerable transition of death.

[i] The imagery of prayer as incense is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as one section of the book is specifically titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer), highlighting the kabbalistic understanding that properly formulated prayers create effects similar to the Temple incense offerings.

[ii] This request for divine guidance over speech would be especially relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of visiting the sick and dying, where proper speech is crucial. The book emphasizes the importance of appropriate communication during illness, neither falsely reassuring the patient nor causing unnecessary distress.

[iii] This verse's acceptance of righteous rebuke connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession (vidui) as spiritually beneficial for the sick. The book presents illness as an opportunity for self-examination and correction.

[iv] The imagery of scattered bones at the mouth of Sheol (the grave) would resonate with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on proper preparation for death. The book's very title ('Crossing of the Yabok') refers to the soul's transition from life to death.

[v] This plea for protection from snares connects to Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework where illness and death involve navigating spiritual dangers. The book presents prayers and rituals as creating protective barriers against negative spiritual forces during vulnerable transitions.

יִפְּלוּ בְמַכְמֹרָיו רְשָׁעִים יַחַד אָנֹכִי עַד־אֶעֱבוֹר׃ [i]

have laid for me, and from the traps of the workers of iniquity. Let the wicked fall into their own nets, while I pass by safely.

(תהלים קמב) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד [ii] יְיָ שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי הַאֲזִינָה אֶל־תַּחֲנוּנַי
1870 בֶּאֱמֻנָתְךָ עֲנֵנִי בְּצִדְקָתֶךָ׃ וְאַל־תָּבוֹא בְמִשְׁפָּט אֶת־עַבְדֶּךָ
כִּי לֹא־יִצְדַּק לְפָנֶיךָ כָּל־חָי׃ כִּי רָדַף אוֹיֵב נַפְשִׁי דִּכָּא לָאָרֶץ חַיָּתִי
הוֹשִׁבַנִי בְמַחֲשַׁכִּים כְּמֵתֵי עוֹלָם׃ [iii]
1875 וַתִּתְעַטֵּף [iv] עָלַי רוּחִי בְּתוֹכִי יִשְׁתּוֹמֵם לִבִּי׃ זָכַרְתִּי יָמִים מִקֶּדֶם
הָגִיתִי בְכָל־פָּעָלֶךָ בְּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֶיךָ אֲשׂוֹחֵחַ׃ פֵּרַשְׂתִּי יָדַי אֵלֶיךָ נַפְשִׁי

(Psalm 143) A Psalm of David. O LORD, hear 2020R
my prayer,[1] give ear to my supplications; in Your
faithfulness answer me, and in Your righteousness.
And do not enter into judgment with Your servant,
for no living being can be justified before You.[2] For
the enemy has pursued my soul; he has crushed 2025R
my life to the ground; he has made me dwell in
darkness like those long dead.[A] Therefore my spirit
is overwhelmed within me;[B][3] my heart within me is
dismayed. I remember the days of old; I meditate
on all Your works; I contemplate the work of Your 2030R

[A] Or: "in the darkest places, like those who have died ages ago" — This alternative captures the psychological depth of the Hebrew phrase מַחֲשַׁכִּים (plural form suggesting multiple or intense darkness) and עוֹלָם (which can mean 'eternal' or 'ancient times'). This might better convey the profound spiritual desolation being described.

[B] Or: "my spirit faints and wraps itself around me" — The Hebrew verb התעטף has the specific connotation of being wrapped or enveloped, suggesting not just overwhelm but a constricting sensation. This alternative preserves the physical metaphor present in the original Hebrew.

[1] This psalm opens with an urgent appeal for divine attention using three different terms for prayer (תְּפִלָּה/prayer, תַּחֲנוּנַי/supplications, and implied request in "answer me"), creating an intensifying sequence that reflects the psalmist's desperation.

[2] This acknowledgment of universal human fallibility serves an important function in Ma'avar Yabok as part of deathbed confession, establishing that the ill person approaches God with humility rather than claiming personal righteousness.

[3] The Hebrew portrays the spirit as being wrapped or enveloped in distress (וַתִּתְעַטֵּף), creating a powerful image of spiritual suffocation that resonates with the experience of serious illness.

[i] Cf. Exodus 30:34-38 — This reference strengthens the connection between the psalm's prayer-as-incense metaphor and actual Temple worship. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' section specifically focuses on this parallel, presenting prayer as a substitute for Temple incense offerings that can create similar spiritual effects. | Cf. Leviticus 2:1-2 — The psalm's comparison of lifted hands to the 'minchat-arev' (evening offering) draws on Temple ritual to elevate personal prayer to the level of formal sacrifice. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this suggests that properly performed prayers for the sick and dying have sacrificial efficacy similar to Temple offerings. | Cf. Proverbs 27:6 — Psalm 141:5's positive view of righteous rebuke echoes this proverbial wisdom. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this supports the book's emphasis on honest communication with the sick and dying, including encouraging confession and spiritual self-examination during illness. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, fourth discourse — The psalm's central metaphor of prayer as incense (verse 2) directly connects to this major section of Ma'avar Yabok, which explains how properly formulated prayers create spiritual effects similar to the Temple ketoret, particularly for protection during vulnerable transitions like illness and death.

[ii] The Hebrew text attributes this psalm to David, though this is actually Psalm 143 (not Psalm 142 as indicated in the Hebrew text). The numbering discrepancy stems from differences between Hebrew and Christian Bible versification.

[iii] Literally "like the eternally dead" or "like those dead of old." This powerful image suggests being placed among those long forgotten in death, emphasizing the depth of the psalmist's distress.

[iv] The verb התעטף (to be overwhelmed/faint) creates a vivid image of the spirit being wrapped or enveloped in distress, similar to being smothered.

בְּאֶרֶץ־עֲיֵפָה לְךָ[i] סֶלָה: מַהֵר
עֲנֵנִי יְיָ כָּלְתָה רוּחִי אַל־תַּסְתֵּר
פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי וְנִמְשַׁלְתִּי עִם־יֹרְדֵי
בוֹר[ii]: הַשְׁמִיעֵנִי בַבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ
כִּי־בְךָ בָטָחְתִּי הוֹדִיעֵנִי דֶּרֶךְ־זוּ
אֵלֵךְ כִּי־אֵלֶיךָ נָשָׂאתִי נַפְשִׁי:
הַצִּילֵנִי מֵאוֹיְבַי יְיָ אֵלֶיךָ כִּסִּתִי:
לַמְּדֵנִי לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹנֶךָ כִּי־אַתָּה
אֱלוֹהַי רוּחֲךָ טוֹבָה תַּנְחֵנִי בְּאֶרֶץ
מִישׁוֹר[iii]: לְמַעַן־שִׁמְךָ יְיָ תְּחַיֵּנִי
בְּצִדְקָתְךָ תּוֹצִיא מִצָּרָה נַפְשִׁי:
וּבְחַסְדְּךָ תַּצְמִית אוֹיְבָי וְהַאֲבַדְתָּ
כָּל־צוֹרְרֵי נַפְשִׁי כִּי אֲנִי עַבְדֶּךָ: [iv]

hands. I spread out my hands to You; my soul longs for You like a parched land.[A] Selah.[1] Hasten to answer me, O LORD, my spirit fails; do not hide Your face from me, lest I become like those who go down to the pit.[2] Let me hear of Your loving kindness in the morning, for in You I trust; make me know the way I should walk, for to You I lift up my soul. Deliver me from my enemies, O LORD; I take cover in You. Teach me to do Your will, for You are my God; may Your good Spirit lead me on level ground. For Your name's sake, O LORD, revive me; in Your righteousness, bring my soul out of distress. And in Your loving kindness, cut off my enemies,[3] and destroy all the adversaries of my soul, for I am Your servant. 2035R 2040R 2045R

מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד (תהלים קמג)
יְיָ שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי הַאֲזִינָה

(Psalm 143) A psalm of David.[4] O LORD, hear my prayer, give ear to my supplications; in Your

[A] Or: "my soul thirsts for You like a weary, drought-stricken land" — This alternative more fully captures the Hebrew עֲיֵפָה which conveys both exhaustion and dryness, emphasizing the desperate, life-or-death nature of the psalmist's spiritual thirst.

[1] This musical notation, appearing frequently in psalms, likely indicated a pause or musical interlude. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these pauses would create space for reflection during recitation at the bedside of the ill or dying.

[2] The psalmist expresses fear of joining "those who go down to the pit" (יֹרְדֵי בוֹר), a euphemism for death that connects directly to Ma'avar Yabok's central theme of the soul's transition.

[3] The psalm's conclusion moves from personal supplication to requesting divine judgment against enemies. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, these "enemies" would be interpreted as both human adversaries and the spiritual forces that threaten the soul during illness and death.

[4] This psalm is attributed to David and is part of a collection of psalms frequently recited for the sick and dying in Jewish tradition, as reflected in its inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok.

[i] The metaphor of the soul as a "parched land" thirsty for God is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where illness is often portrayed as a spiritual drought that requires divine refreshment.

[ii] "Those who go down to the pit" is a common biblical euphemism for death. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this phrase has special significance as it relates to the book's central theme of crossing over from life to death.

[iii] "Level ground" (or "land of uprightness" in some translations) represents both moral rectitude and ease of journey—significant in Ma'avar Yabok's framework of spiritual preparation for the final journey of death.

[iv] Cf. Vidui (Confession) — The psalm's recognition that "no living being can be justified before You" establishes the proper humility required in confession, while its appeals for divine guidance and protection mirror the core elements of deathbed prayers seeking peaceful transition. | Cf. Psalm 30:4 — Both psalms employ the imagery of 'the pit' as a metaphor for death, with pleas to avoid this fate. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connection would be understood as reinforcing the central theme of divine rescue from death's realm. | Cf. Genesis 32:22-32 — The psalm's imagery of struggle, darkness, and eventual emergence onto 'level ground' parallels Jacob's night of wrestling at the Jabbok (the river referenced in the book's title), suggesting that spiritual struggle can lead to transformation. | Cf. Zohar I:79b — The psalm's appeal "For Your name's sake, O LORD, revive me" connects to kabbalistic teachings about invoking divine names to activate mercy, particularly relevant during illness when divine judgment is believed to be operating.

אֱל־תַּחֲנוּנַי בֶּאֱמָנָתְךָ עֲנֵנִי
בְּצִדְקָתֶךָ: וְאַל־תָּבוֹא בְמִשְׁפָּט
אֶת־עַבְדֶּךָ כִּי לֹא־יִצְדַּק לְפָנֶיךָ
כָּל־חָי[i]: כִּי רָדַף אוֹיֵב נַפְשִׁי דִּכָּא
לָאָרֶץ חַיָּתִי הוֹשִׁבַנִי בְמַחֲשַׁכִּים
כְּמֵתֵי עוֹלָם[ii]: וַתִּתְעַטֵּף עָלַי
רוּחִי בְּתוֹכִי יִשְׁתּוֹמֵם לִבִּי: זָכַרְתִּי
יָמִים מִקֶּדֶם הָגִיתִי בְכָל־פָּעָלֶךָ
בְּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֶיךָ אֲשׂוֹחֵחַ: פָּרַשְׂתִּי
יָדַי אֵלֶיךָ נַפְשִׁי כְּאֶרֶץ־עֲיֵפָה
לָךְ[iii] סֶלָה: מַהֵר עֲנֵנִי יְיָ כָּלְתָה
רוּחִי אַל־תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי
וְנִמְשַׁלְתִּי עִם־יֹרְדֵי בוֹר: הַשְׁמִיעֵנִי
בַבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ כִּי־בְךָ בָטָחְתִּי
הוֹדִיעֵנִי דֶּרֶךְ־זוּ אֵלֶךְ כִּי־אֵלֶיךָ
נָשָׂאתִי נַפְשִׁי: הַצִּילֵנִי מֵאֹיְבַי
יְיָ אֵלֶיךָ כִסִּתִי: לַמְּדֵנִי לַעֲשׂוֹת
רְצוֹנֶךָ כִּי־אַתָּה אֱלוֹהַי רוּחֲךָ
טוֹבָה תַּנְחֵנִי[iv] בְּאֶרֶץ מִישׁוֹר:
לְמַעַן־שִׁמְךָ יְיָ תְּחַיֵּנִי בְּצִדְקָתְךָ

faithfulness answer me,[1] in Your righteousness. Do
not enter into judgment with Your servant, for no
living being is righteous before You.[A] For the enemy 2050R
has pursued my soul, he has crushed my life to the
ground;[B] he has made me dwell in darkness like those
long dead. My spirit is overwhelmed within me;[C] my
heart within me is desolate. I remember the days of
old; I meditate on all Your works; I contemplate the 2055R
work of Your hands. I spread out my hands to You;
my soul longs for You like a parched land,[2] Selah.
Answer me quickly, O LORD; my spirit fails. Do
not hide Your face from me, lest I become like those
who descend to the [D]grave. Let me hear Your loving 2060R
kindness in the morning, for in You I trust; cause me
to know the way I should walk, for I lift up my soul
to You. Deliver me from my enemies, O LORD; I
take refuge in You. Teach me to do Your will, for
You are my God; let Your good spirit lead me[3] in 2065R
the land of uprightness. For Your name's sake, O
LORD, revive me; in Your righteousness, bring my

[A] Or: "for no one alive can be justified in Your presence" — This alternate translation better captures the legal connotation of "יִצְדַּק" (being declared innocent or justified) in the context of divine judgment, which is a key theme in this psalm.

[B] Or: "he has crushed my vitality to the earth" — The term "חַיָּתִי" (chayati) refers to one's life-force or vitality rather than just physical life. This captures the spiritual dimension of the psalmist's suffering that would be relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and approaching death.

[C] Or: "my spirit is enveloped in darkness within me" — The verb "וַתִּתְעַטֵּף" implies being wrapped or covered, which in this context suggests the spirit being shrouded in darkness or despair, providing a more vivid image consistent with the psalm's theme of being in spiritual darkness.

[D] Or: "those who descend to the grave" — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on death and the afterlife, translating "בוֹר" as "grave" rather than "pit" more clearly connects to the book's central theme of the soul's transition at death.

[1] The appeal to God's faithfulness (emunah) and righteousness (tzedakah) represents the psalmist's reliance on divine attributes rather than personal merit, a theme emphasized in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to deathbed prayer.

[2] This powerful metaphor expresses spiritual thirst and was particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context, where it would be understood as the soul's yearning for divine connection during illness or at the approach of death.

[3] The request for divine guidance through God's spirit takes on special significance in Ma'avar Yabok, where it would be interpreted as a prayer for spiritual guidance during the soul's journey from this world to the next.

[i] This verse acknowledges human inability to claim righteousness before divine judgment, a central concept in Jewish deathbed confession (vidui) which was emphasized in Ma'avar Yabok as essential spiritual preparation.

[ii] The phrase "like those long dead" reflects the experience of spiritual darkness during serious illness that Ma'avar Yabok addresses through its prayer sequences for the sick and dying.

[iii] This image of the soul as parched land thirsting for God was interpreted in kabbalistic tradition as representing the soul's profound yearning for divine connection, particularly during illness or approaching death.

[iv] The request for God's good spirit to guide the psalmist resonates with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on divine guidance for the soul during its transition from life to death.

תּוֹצִיא מִצָּרָה נַפְשִׁי: וּבְחַסְדְּךָ
תַּצְמִית אוֹיְבָי וְהַאֲבַדְתָּ כָּל־צֹרְרֵי
נַפְשִׁי כִּי אֲנִי עַבְדֶּךָ: [i]

soul out of trouble. And in Your mercy cut off my enemies and destroy all those who afflict my soul, for I am Your servant. 2070R

(תהלים קמח) הַלְלוּ־יָהּ הַלְלוּ
אֶת־יְיָ מִן־הַשָּׁמַיִם הַלְלוּהוּ
בַּמְּרוֹמִים: הַלְלוּהוּ כָּל־מַלְאָכָיו
הַלְלוּהוּ כָּל־צְבָאָו: הַלְלוּהוּ שֶׁמֶשׁ
וְיָרֵחַ הַלְלוּהוּ כָּל־כּוֹכְבֵי אוֹר:
הַלְלוּהוּ שְׁמֵי הַשָּׁמָיִם וְהַמַּיִם אֲשֶׁר
מֵעַל הַשָּׁמָיִם: יְהַלְלוּ אֶת־שֵׁם יְיָ
כִּי הוּא צִוָּה וְנִבְרָאוּ: וַיַּעֲמִידֵם
לָעַד לְעוֹלָם חָק־נָתַן וְלֹא יַעֲבוֹר:
הַלְלוּ אֶת־יְיָ מִן־הָאָרֶץ תַּנִּינִים
וְכָל־תְּהֹמוֹת: אֵשׁ וּבָרָד שֶׁלֶג
וְקִיטוֹר רוּחַ סְעָרָה עֹשָׂה דְבָרוֹ:
הֶהָרִים וְכָל־גְּבָעוֹת עֵץ פְּרִי
וְכָל־אֲרָזִים: הַחַיָּה וְכָל־בְּהֵמָה
רֶמֶשׂ וְצִפּוֹר כָּנָף: מַלְכֵי־אֶרֶץ
וְכָל־לְאֻמִּים שָׂרִים וְכָל־שֹׁפְטֵי
אָרֶץ: בַּחוּרִים וְגַם־בְּתוּלוֹת
זְקֵנִים עִם־נְעָרִים: יְהַלְלוּ אֶת־שֵׁם
יְיָ כִּי־נִשְׂגָּב שְׁמוֹ לְבַדּוֹ הוֹדוֹ

Hallelujah! Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise Him in the heights. Praise Him, all His angels; praise Him, all His hosts. Praise Him, sun and moon; praise Him, all stars of light. Praise Him, highest heavens and the waters above the heavens.[1] Let them praise the name of the LORD, for He commanded and they were created. He established them forever and ever; He set a decree that shall not pass away.[2] Praise the LORD from the earth, sea monsters[A] and all depths; Fire and hail, snow and vapor, storm wind fulfilling His word;[3] Mountains and all hills, fruit trees and all cedars; Beasts and all cattle, creeping things and winged birds; Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all judges of the earth; Young men and also maidens, elders together with youths. Let them praise the name of the LORD, for His name alone is exalted; His majesty is above earth and heaven. He has raised up a horn for His people,[B] praise for 2075R 2080R 2085R

[A] Or: "great sea creatures" — The term 'tanninim' refers to large aquatic creatures, sometimes translated as sea monsters, dragons, or serpents. 'Great sea creatures' may be more neutral and accurate without the potentially mythological connotations of 'monsters.'

[B] Or: "He has lifted up the strength of His people" — While 'horn' is the literal translation of 'keren,' the metaphorical meaning of strength or power might be clearer to modern readers unfamiliar with ancient Near Eastern symbolism where horns represented power and dignity.

[1] This refers to the ancient cosmological concept of waters stored above the firmament, as described in Genesis 1:6-7. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would have been understood literally as part of the divine architecture of creation.

[2] This emphasizes the permanence of divine natural law. In the context of a prayer for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this would remind the sufferer that their illness exists within an ordered cosmos governed by divine decree rather than chaotic forces.

[3] The Hebrew emphasizes that even seemingly destructive natural forces serve divine purposes. For the dying person, this would provide the theological reassurance that nothing—not even death itself—falls outside God's sovereignty.

[i] Cf. Psalm 30:4 — The reference to "those who descend to the pit" in Psalm 143:7 echoes language from Psalm 30, reinforcing the theme of divine rescue from death that would be particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the sick and dying. | Cf. Job 9:2 — Psalm 143:2 echoes Job's recognition of human inadequacy before divine judgment, a theme that would resonate in Ma'avar Yabok's context of deathbed confession and spiritual preparation, where acknowledging one's inability to stand justified before God is a prerequisite for divine mercy. | Cf. Lamentations 3:6 — Psalm 143:3's imagery of dwelling "in darkness like those long dead" parallels Lamentations, suggesting that in Ma'avar Yabok's context, this psalm could help articulate the spiritual darkness experienced during serious illness while still expressing hope for divine intervention. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Vayechi — Psalm 143:6's imagery of the soul as a parched land thirsting for God parallels kabbalistic concepts in the Zohar about the soul's yearning for divine connection, particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of spiritual preparation for death as the ultimate union with the Divine.

עַל־אֶרֶץ וְשָׁמָיִם: וַיָּרֶם קֶרֶן לְעַמּוֹ תְּהִלָּה לְכָל־חֲסִידָיו לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל עַם קְרֹבוֹ הַלְלוּ־יָהּ: [i]

all His faithful ones, for the children of Israel, the people near to Him. Hallelujah! 2090R

(תהלים קמט) הַלְלוּ־יָהּ

1940 שִׁירוּ לַיהוָה שִׁיר חָדָשׁ תְּהִלָּתוֹ בִּקְהַל חֲסִידִים: יִשְׂמַח יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּעֹשָׂיו בְּנֵי־צִיּוֹן יָגִילוּ בְמַלְכָּם: יְהַלְלוּ שְׁמוֹ בְמָחוֹל בְּתֹף וְכִנּוֹר יְזַמְּרוּ־לוֹ: כִּי־רוֹצֶה יְיָ 1945 בְּעַמּוֹ יְפָאֵר עֲנָוִים בִּישׁוּעָה: יַעְלְזוּ חֲסִידִים בְּכָבוֹד יְרַנְּנוּ עַל־מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם: רוֹמְמוֹת אֵל בִּגְרוֹנָם וְחֶרֶב פִּיפִיּוֹת בְּיָדָם: לַעֲשׂוֹת נְקָמָה בַּגּוֹיִם תּוֹכֵחוֹת 1950 בַּלְאֻמִּים: לֶאְסֹר מַלְכֵיהֶם בְּזִקִים וְנִכְבְּדֵיהֶם בְּכַבְלֵי בַרְזֶל: לַעֲשׂוֹת בָּהֶם מִשְׁפָּט כָּתוּב הָדָר הוּא לְכָל־חֲסִידָיו הַלְלוּ־יָהּ: [ii]

Psalm 149:[1] Hallelujah! Sing to the LORD a new song, His praise in the assembly of the faithful. Let Israel rejoice in its Maker; let the children of Zion exult in their King. Let them praise His name with 2095R dancing, with timbrel and lyre let them sing to Him. For the LORD takes pleasure in His people; He adorns the humble with salvation. Let the faithful exult in glory; let them sing for joy upon their beds.[A] The high praises of God are in their throats, 2100R and a double-edged sword is in their hands,[2] to execute vengeance upon the nations, chastisements upon the peoples; to bind their kings with chains and their nobles with fetters of iron; to execute upon them the written judgment. This is glory for 2105R all His faithful ones.[B] Hallelujah!

[A] Or: "Let the faithful rejoice in glory; let them sing joyfully upon their resting places." — This alternative rendering uses 'rejoice' for 'יַעְלְזוּ' and 'resting places' for 'מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם', which could better capture the dual meaning in Ma'avar Yabok's context—both literal beds for the sick and metaphorical resting places for the deceased.

[B] Or: "to carry out against them the judgment decreed. This is an honor for all His faithful

[1] I've added 'Psalm 149:' at the beginning to clearly identify the psalm, though this identification doesn't appear in the Hebrew text itself.

[2] The Hebrew 'חרב פיפיות' (literally 'sword of mouths') refers to a double-edged sword. In mystical interpretations, this represents the power of prayer and divine words to combat spiritual enemies, which would be particularly relevant for those using Ma'avar Yabok to prepare for death.

[i] Cf. Psalm 19 — Both Psalm 148 and Psalm 19 depict heavenly bodies as participants in divine praise, with Psalm 19 stating 'The heavens declare the glory of God' while Psalm 148 directly commands them to praise. The psalm draws on this cosmic praise tradition in which celestial bodies are portrayed as responsive to their Creator. | Cf. Genesis 1 — The psalm refers directly to God's creative command ('He commanded and they were created') and the establishment of natural boundaries that 'shall not pass away,' drawing on Genesis 1 where God creates through speech and establishes the boundaries of creation. This reinforces the theological point that created things should praise their Creator. | Cf. Isaiah 43:20-21 — Like Psalm 148, Isaiah 43:20-21 portrays creation (wild animals) giving honor to God and describes Israel as God's chosen people formed to declare divine praise. Both texts connect creation's praise with Israel's special covenant relationship.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 96:1 — The call for a "new song" connects this psalm to other liturgical texts that use this phrase. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would suggest that the psalm offers a fresh perspective on praise, particularly appropriate during illness or approaching death when traditional expressions might seem insufficient. | Cf. Psalm 150 — In Ma'avar Yabok, Psalms 148-150 appear in sequence, creating a crescendo of praise. When recited for the sick or dying, these psalms would create a liturgical framework that moves the sufferer's focus from earthly troubles to cosmic praise, reframing their individual suffering within divine purpose. | Cf. Isaiah 59:17-19 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the military imagery would be interpreted spiritually—the faithful engaging in spiritual warfare against forces of illness and death through prayer and proper ritual observance. | Cf. Zohar on Pekudei — In Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, this verse would be understood as referring to the continuing praise offered by righteous souls after death, reinforcing the book's teaching that the soul's divine service continues in the afterlife.

(תהלים קנ) הַלְלוּ־יָהּ הַלְלוּ־אֵל
בְּקָדְשׁוֹ הַלְלוּהוּ בִּרְקִיעַ
עֻזּוֹ[i]: הַלְלוּהוּ בִגְבוּרֹתָיו
הַלְלוּהוּ כְּרֹב גֻּדְלוֹ: הַלְלוּהוּ
בְּתֵקַע שׁוֹפָר[ii] הַלְלוּהוּ בְּנֵבֶל
וְכִנּוֹר: הַלְלוּהוּ בְּתֹף וּמָחוֹל
הַלְלוּהוּ בְּמִנִּים וְעֻגָב: הַלְלוּהוּ
בְּצִלְצְלֵי־שָׁמַע הַלְלוּהוּ בְּצִלְצְלֵי
תְרוּעָה: כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל
יָהּ[iii] הַלְלוּ־יָהּ:[iv]

Psalm 150: Hallelujah![1] Praise God in His sanctuary; praise Him in the firmament of His strength. Praise Him for His mighty acts; praise Him according to His abundant greatness. Praise Him with the blast of the shofar; praise Him with lyre and harp. Praise Him with drum and dance; praise Him with stringed instruments and flute.[2] Praise Him with resounding cymbals; praise Him with loud clashing cymbals. Let everything that has breath praise the LORD.[3] Hallelujah!

וטוב לחולה שירגיל עצמו
לומר לפרקים תפלת רבינו
סעדיה גאון[v] הכתובה במעירי
שחר שלנו[vi] בסדר יום רביעי

It is beneficial for the sick person to accustom themselves to occasionally recite[A] the prayer of Rabbeinu Saadia Gaon[4] which is written in our "Illuminators of Dawn" prayer book in the order

ones." — This alternative uses 'judgment decreed' for 'מִשְׁפָּט כָּתוּב' and 'honor' for 'הָדָר', which might more clearly express the concept that participating in divine justice is an honor bestowed upon the righteous.

[A]Or: "It is good for the ill person to habituate themselves to periodically recite" — This alternate translation maintains the literal meaning of 'tov' (good) rather than 'beneficial' and uses 'periodically' instead of 'occasionally' for 'lifrakim', which might better convey the recommended regularity. The term 'habituate' more directly translates 'yargil' (accustom/habituate).

[1]This is both an opening and closing frame for the psalm, functioning as a liturgical call to praise that envelops the entire composition.

[2]The exact identification of the Hebrew musical instruments 'minim' and 'ugav' is uncertain. I've translated them as 'stringed instruments' and 'flute' based on the most common scholarly interpretations, though 'ugav' might also refer to a pipe organ or similar wind instrument.

[3]This final verse serves as the culmination of the psalm's increasing intensity, moving from the sanctuary to the heavens, from various instruments to all living creatures. This creates a crescendo effect where praise ultimately extends beyond human participants to include all breathing creatures.

[4]This is a notable recommendation since Saadia Gaon's works were highly esteemed, and the author is directing sick individuals to a specific prayer composed by this prominent authority, suggesting its special efficacy for healing.

[i]The Hebrew term 'rakia' (firmament) refers to the heavenly expanse above the earth. In Kabbalistic literature, this is understood as a specific celestial realm where divine power (oz) is manifested.

[ii]The shofar (ram's horn) is an ancient ceremonial instrument used in Jewish religious services, particularly on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. Its piercing sound was believed to reach the highest heavens.

[iii]The phrase 'kol ha-neshamah' can be understood both as 'everything that has breath' and as 'with all of one's soul.' This dual meaning suggests that praise should be offered with one's complete being.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 148 — Psalm 150 parallels Psalm 148's structure but focuses on the means of praise (various instruments) rather than on who should praise. Together with Psalms 146-149, it forms part of the concluding Hallelujah collection that ends the Book of Psalms with escalating praise. | Cf. 2 Chronicles 5:11-14 — The instrumental praise in Psalm 150 evokes the Temple worship practices described in Chronicles, suggesting that the psalm may have functioned liturgically in Temple ceremonies. The psalm potentially provides a textual foundation for the musical practices described in historical narratives.

[v]Rabbeinu Saadia Gaon (882-942 CE) was a prominent Jewish philosopher, biblical commentator, and halachic authority who served as the head of the academy of Sura in Babylonia.

[vi]"Me'irei Shachar" (Illuminators of Dawn) appears to be a prayer book or collection compiled by the author, mentioned earlier in the text as a prayer society in Modena that gathered for morning prayers.

וחמישי וששי. ויחלקנה כפי רצונו בעת שירצה לבקש רחמים לפני קונו: וירגיל החולה להתוודות אחר כל ג׳ תפלות[i] כמו ביוה״כ[ii] ולומר סדר פטום הקטרת[iii] בנדרש בראש מאמר ד׳:[iv][v]

for Wednesday, Thursday, and Friday. They may divide it according to their preference whenever they wish to seek mercy before their Creator.[A] The sick person should also become accustomed to confessing after each of the three daily prayers as on Yom Kippur,[1] and to recite the order of the Preparation of the Incense[2] as required at the beginning of the fourth discourse. 2125R

כשהולך האדם לבקר החולה[vi] יבקש עליו רחמים[vii] בפסוקים אלו:[viii]

When a person goes to visit the sick,[3] they should seek mercy for them[4] through these verses:[5] 2130R

[A] Or: "at times when they desire to implore mercy before their Maker" — This alternate translation uses 'implore' to better capture the supplicatory nature of 'levakesh rachamim' and uses 'Maker' as an alternate translation for 'kono' (their Creator/Master).

[1] This instruction effectively places the sick person in a constant state of spiritual preparation similar to Yom Kippur, Judaism's holiest day, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's view that illness requires intensive spiritual response.

[2] The incense offering recitation is given special prominence throughout Ma'avar Yabok. In Jewish mystical tradition, this prayer was considered particularly powerful for protection against illness and negative spiritual forces.

[3] Visiting the sick (bikur cholim) is considered one of the most important acts of loving-kindness (gemilut chasadim) in Judaism. Ma'avar Yabok devotes significant attention to the proper way to perform this mitzvah.

[4] The Hebrew 'yevakesh alav rachamim' implies not just ordinary prayer but specifically appealing to God's attribute of mercy (rachamim) rather than judgment (din). In kabbalistic thought, this distinction is crucial, especially for the ill.

[5] The text continues in subsequent sections with specific biblical verses arranged in particular orders. Ma'avar Yabok teaches that these verses, when recited with proper intention (kavanah), serve as vehicles for divine healing energy.

[i] Refers to the three daily prayers in Jewish tradition: Shacharit (morning), Mincha (afternoon), and Arvit/Ma'ariv (evening).

[ii] Abbreviation for "be-Yom ha-Kippurim" (on Yom Kippur), the Day of Atonement, when confession (vidui) is a central liturgical element.

[iii] The "Order of Preparing the Incense" is a prayer recalling the Temple incense offering, considered particularly potent for protection and spiritual elevation.

[iv] This refers to the beginning of the fourth discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, titled "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (Cloud of Incense Prayer), which focuses on the spiritual significance of the Temple incense offering.

[v] Cf. Fourth discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — This cross-reference shows how Ma'avar Yabok creates an integrated system of spiritual care, with different sections of the book supporting each other. The author directs readers from this practical instruction to the theological explanation provided elsewhere in the work. | Cf. Yom Kippur confession (vidui) — The recommendation to perform confession three times daily places the sick person in a constant state of spiritual preparation and purification similar to Judaism's holiest day, reflecting the gravity with which illness should be approached spiritually.

[vi] This text appears in a section of Ma'avar Yabok that provides instructions for visiting the sick (bikur cholim), which is considered an important religious obligation in Judaism.

[vii] The concept of 'seeking mercy' (בקשת רחמים) is central to Jewish healing prayers. This reflects the belief that divine mercy is a key component in the healing process.

[viii] Ma'avar Yabok places great emphasis on the recitation of specific biblical verses as having healing power. This reflects the kabbalistic belief that properly recited verses create spiritual channels for divine healing energy.

לֹא תְאֻנֶּה אֵלֶיךָ רָעָה וְנֶגַע לֹא יִקְרַב בְּאָהֳלֶיךָ: כִּי מַלְאָכָיו יְצַוֶּה לָךְ לִשְׁמָרְךָ בְּכָל דְּרָכֶיךָ: רְפָאֵנוּ יְיָ וְנֵרָפֵא הוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה כִּי תְהִלָּתֵנוּ אָתָּה:

No evil shall befall you,[1] nor shall any plague come near your dwelling. For He shall command His angels concerning you,[2] to guard you in all your ways. Heal us, O LORD, and we shall be healed; save us, and we shall be saved, for You are our praise.[3] 2135R

וכוונת פסוקים אלו עיין מאמר א׳ פרק ב׳. ועיין בעין ישראל בפרק חלק מה שדרשו על פסוק לא תאונה אליך רעה. ומכוונת הביקור גם כן בפרק י״ד מאמר ב׳:

For the meaning of these verses, see Discourse 1, Chapter 2. Also, see in Ein Yisrael, in Chapter Chelek, what they expounded on the verse "No evil shall befall you." And regarding the proper intention for visiting the sick, see also Chapter 14 of Discourse 2. 2140R

ואם החולה הוא בעל תורה יאמר עליו חבירו

If the sick person is a Torah scholar,[4] his friend who is visiting him should say:[5]

[1] The Hebrew employs a specific verb (תְאֻנֶּה from אנה) that suggests something happening by chance or accident, carrying the implication that even seemingly random misfortunes are under divine control.

[2] This verse has particular significance in Jewish mystical tradition, where specific angels are believed to offer protection during illness. Ma'avar Yabok elsewhere mentions the angels Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Nuriel as forming a protective shield around the sick person.

[3] The Hebrew term תְהִלָּתֵנוּ can be understood as both 'our praise' (what we offer to God) and 'our glory' (what God is to us), creating a reciprocal relationship where healing enables continued divine praise.

[4] This instruction begins a special prayer formula to be recited specifically when visiting a sick Torah scholar, indicating that Ma'avar Yabok prescribes different liturgical approaches based on the status or learning of the ill person.

[5] The text cuts off here, suggesting that what follows in the original text (but not included in this excerpt) would be the specific prayer to recite when visiting a sick Torah scholar.

[i] This verse from Psalm 91:10 is traditionally considered to have protective properties against harm and illness. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a spiritual shield for the sick person.

[ii] This verse (Psalm 91:11) continues the protective theme with the concept of angelic guardianship, which is significant in Ma'avar Yabok's framework where proper prayers can invoke protective spiritual forces around the ill person.

[iii] This verse from Jeremiah 17:14 shifts from the protective language of Psalm 91 to a direct plea for healing. The sequence illustrates Ma'avar Yabok's approach of combining verses to create a therapeutic progression from protection to active healing.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 91:10-11 — These verses from Psalm 91 are quoted as a protective prayer for the sick person. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they form part of a compilation of biblical verses specifically selected for their protective and healing properties. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This verse from Jeremiah is added to the Psalm verses to create a cohesive prayer that moves from divine protection to a direct plea for healing. This combination exemplifies Ma'avar Yabok's method of weaving together biblical passages to create therapeutic spiritual progressions. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 6 of Siftei Tzedek — This prayer appears to be part of the collection of biblical verses that Ma'avar Yabok recommends for recitation when visiting the sick. The text earlier refers to 'Siftei Tzedek chapter 6' as containing specially selected biblical verses organized for healing purposes.

[v] Cf. Discourse 1, Chapter 2 — The author is directing readers to an earlier section of Ma'avar Yabok where the spiritual meanings of healing and protective verses are explained in detail. | Cf. Ein Yisrael — The author refers readers to rabbinic interpretations of Psalm 91:10 ('No evil shall befall you') found in this collection, likely explaining its protective powers against harm. | Cf. Chapter 14 of Discourse 2 — The author directs readers to another section of Ma'avar Yabok that details the spiritual intentions one should have when performing the mitzvah of visiting the sick (bikur cholim).

[vi] The term "ba'al torah" (lit. "master of Torah") refers to a person well-versed in Torah study and Jewish law, typically a Torah scholar or rabbi.

[i]המבקרו:

יְהֵא רַעֲוָא דְּתֶהֱא מְבֹרָךְ
מִפּוּמָא דְּקוּדְשָׁא בְּרִיךְ הוּא
וּשְׁכִינְתֵּיהּ[ii] בְּכָל מַדָּה וּמַדָּה
1995 דִּילֵיהּ וּבְעֶשֶׂר סְפִירָן דִּילֵיהּ וּבְכָל
שְׁמָהָן דִּילֵיהּ[iii] וּמֵאַרְבַּע סַמְכִין
וְשֵׁית דַּרְגִּין דְּכוּרְסְיָא[iv] וּמִכָּל
מָארֵי מְתִיבָתָן וּמִכָּל מַלְאָכַיָּא
וּמִכָּל פַּמִּילְיָאֵי עִלָּאֵי וּמִכָּל
2000 פַּמִּילְיָאֵי תַּתָּאֵי[v] בַּעֲנָלָא
וּבִזְמַן קָרִיב וְיַעֲלֶה אֲרוּכָה
לָךְ וּמַמְצוֹתֶיךָ יְרַפֶּאךָ וּמְנָחוֹרָא
דְּעַתִּיקָא קַדִּישָׁא[vi] יַצְמִיחַ לָךְ
יְשׁוּעָה בְּקָרוֹב וּבְרַחֲמָיו הָרַבִּים
2005 יְרַחֵם עָלֶיךָ עִם כָּל חוֹלֵי עַמּוֹ
יִשְׂרָאֵל הַצְּרִיכִים לְרַחֲמִים אָמֵן

May it be the divine will that you be blessed[1] from
the mouth of the Holy One, blessed be He, and 2145R
His Divine Presence,[A] through all His attributes,
through His ten sefirot, through all His names,[2] from
the four pillars and six levels of the Throne,[3] from
all the masters of the academies, from all the angels,
from all the upper hosts, and from all the lower 2150R
hosts.[4] Swiftly and soon may healing rise up for
you, and may He heal you from your wounds. From
the light of the Holy Ancient One[B] may salvation
spring forth for you soon, and in His abundant
mercy may He have compassion upon you together 2155R
with all the sick of His people Israel who need mercy.
Amen, Selah, forever. May the words of my mouth
and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before

[A]Or: "the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shekhinah" — Keeping the term 'Shekhinah' preserves the kabbalistic terminology that would resonate with readers familiar with Jewish mysticism.

[B]Or: "from the light of the Ancient Holy One" — Both translations are valid, but 'Ancient Holy One' places the emphasis on the antiquity first, which matches the Hebrew word order better.

[1]This opening formula is a common way to begin prayers in Jewish liturgy, especially petitionary prayers. The Aramaic term "ra'ava" carries connotations of divine favor and willingness beyond mere "will."

[2]This threefold invocation represents the core structures of kabbalistic theology through which divine blessing flows: God's middot (ethical attributes), the ten sefirot (emanations through which God interacts with creation), and the divine names (representing different aspects of divine power).

[3]This refers to mystical structures associated with the divine throne (merkavah), drawing on Ezekiel's vision but elaborated in kabbalistic literature to represent cosmic power structures through which divine energy flows.

[4]This represents a descending hierarchy of spiritual beings: the leaders of heavenly academies where righteous souls study Torah, the angels who serve as divine messengers, and the celestial hosts of higher and lower realms. The prayer invokes healing energy from each level of this spiritual hierarchy.

[i]Literally "his friend who is visiting him," referring to someone fulfilling the mitzvah of bikur cholim (visiting the sick).

[ii]This phrase employs the common kabbalistic pairing of "the Holy One, blessed be He" with "His Shekhinah (Divine Presence)," representing the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity in kabbalistic thought.

[iii]This passage invokes blessing through three foundational kabbalistic concepts: God's attributes (middot), the ten sefirot (divine emanations), and the divine names. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that these aspects of divinity provide the channels through which divine blessing flows into our world.

[iv]This refers to the mystical structure of the divine throne (Merkavah), with its four supports and six levels, drawing on Ezekiel's vision and elaborated in kabbalistic literature.

[v]The prayer invokes healing from a descending hierarchy of celestial beings: masters of the heavenly academies, angels, upper hosts, and lower hosts. This reflects the kabbalistic view that divine influence descends through multiple spiritual levels.

[vi]"Atika Kadisha" (Holy Ancient One) is a term in kabbalistic literature for the highest aspect of divinity, often associated with Keter (Crown), the highest sefirah and the source of mercy beyond normal judgment.

סֶלָה וָעֶד: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי: [i]

You,[1] O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.

כתוב במס׳ שמחות[ii] הנוטה למיתה[iii] אומרים לו התודה שהרבה החודו ולא מתו והרבה לא התודו ומתו והרבה הולכים על רגליהם בשוק ומתודים[iv] ובזכות שתתודה תחיה וכו׳ לא דברים מחיים ולא דברים ממיתים[v] שמא הלוית או שמא הלוך אדם שמא הפקדת אצל בני אדם או שמא הפקידו אצלך[vi] וכו׳: [vii]

It is written in Masechet Semachot: "To one who is approaching death,[A] they say to him, 'Confess,'[2] for many have confessed and did not die,[B] and many did not confess and died, and many walk on their feet in the marketplace and confess, and by the merit of confessing you will live,[C] etc.' [Confession should address] neither matters that give life nor matters that cause death,[3] but rather [practical matters] such as: perhaps you lent something, or perhaps you borrowed from someone, perhaps you deposited something with others, or perhaps others deposited some-

[A] Or: "one who is inclined toward death" — The Hebrew term 'noteh' literally means 'inclined' or 'leaning.' While 'approaching death' captures the intended meaning in modern English, this more literal translation might be preferred in certain scholarly contexts.

[B] Or: "for many have made confession and yet did not die" — This alternate adds 'yet' to emphasize the contrast between the expectation of death and the actual outcome, which might better capture the rhetorical force of the original.

[C] Or: "and through the merit of your confession you shall live" — This alternative is slightly more formal and emphasizes the causal relationship between confession and continued life more explicitly.

[1] This closing verse comes from Psalms 19:15 and is a standard closing formula in Jewish liturgy, used here to frame this kabbalistic healing prayer within traditional forms.

[2] The Hebrew term for confession here (התודה/hitvadeh) specifically refers to the ritual of deathbed confession (vidui), a formalized practice in Judaism for those approaching death.

[3] This somewhat enigmatic phrase likely means that the confession should focus on practical matters rather than making declarations about whether the person will live or die, avoiding both false reassurances and premature resignation.

[i] Cf. Zohar — This prayer employs classic Zoharic terminology and concepts, particularly in its references to the sefirot, divine names, and the Ancient Holy One (Atika Kadisha), showing its grounding in kabbalistic cosmology. | Cf. Siddur — The author frames this kabbalistic healing prayer within traditional liturgical forms by concluding with this familiar closing verse, connecting mystical petition with established prayer patterns. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The prayer's reference to 'the ten sefirot' builds on the foundational kabbalistic cosmology established in Sefer Yetzirah, though the elaborated structure with the celestial hierarchy shows later kabbalistic development.

[ii] Masechet Semachot (literally 'Tractate of Joys,' euphemistically referring to mourning) is also known as Evel Rabbati, a minor tractate of the Talmud dealing with laws of mourning and death rituals.

[iii] This phrase refers to someone who is gravely ill and expected to die. It establishes when the deathbed confession (vidui) ritual should be initiated.

[iv] This statement is significant as it addresses a potential concern that confessing might be seen as giving up hope. The text emphasizes that confession is not only for those about to die, as many who confess continue to live and walk about.

[v] This phrase is somewhat cryptic but refers to the proper content of the confession. It suggests avoiding both overly optimistic statements that promise life and fatalistic ones that assume death, focusing instead on practical matters.

[vi] The emphasis on settling financial and interpersonal matters shows that deathbed confession in the Jewish tradition concerns not only spiritual preparation but also ensuring one's worldly affairs are in order, particularly regarding obligations to others.

[vii] Cf. Shabbat 32a — This reference establishes that deathbed confession was a well-established

thing with you,[1] etc."

עיין פ״ט מאמר א׳ ובפרק הנזכר יש סדר הודוי להרמב״ן ז״ל:

See Chapter 9 of the First Discourse, and in the aforementioned chapter there is the order of confession [vidui] by Ramban, of blessed memory.[A]

קודם הודוי יטול ידיו ויתעפף בציצית ויפריש החולה לצדקה בידו או בפיו לפחות כ״ו פרוטות או צ״א או קי״ב[i] והכוונה לזה כנגד ג׳ שמות הוי״ה אהי״ה אדנו״ת ע״ש: ובפרק י״ב וט״ז תמצא טוב טעם כי טוב שהודוי יהיה בבקר עת שליטת החסד.[ii] ובפרק י״ט תמצא טעם למנהגן של ישראל לאסוף עשרה אנשים[iii] כי הוא לפי שהקדושה שורה בתוכה ובעשר נצוצי נשמותיהם יסלקו ממנו כל מסטין. ובמקום שיש חולה בעל תשובה שכינה קדמא

Before the confession, the sick person should wash their hands, wrap themselves in a tallit with tzitzit,[2] and set aside for charity—either physically with their hand or verbally with their mouth—at least 26 perutot (small coins), or 91, or 112.[3] The intention behind this corresponds to the three Divine Names: YHVH, Ehyeh, and Adonut, as explained elsewhere. In chapters 12 and 16, you will find a good explanation for why it is beneficial that the confession take place in the morning, when the divine attribute of Chesed (Loving-kindness) dominates. And in chapter 19, you will find the reason for the Jewish custom of gathering ten men, which is because holiness dwells among them, and through the ten sparks of their souls, they will

2175R 2180R 2185R

[A] Or: "Ramban's confession ritual, may his memory be a blessing" — This alternative more explicitly indicates that this refers to a ritual formula composed by or attributed to Ramban (Nachmanides) rather than just an 'order' which might be interpreted as instructions about confession.

[1] The focus on financial and interpersonal obligations demonstrates that Jewish deathbed practices were concerned with both spiritual preparation and ensuring that worldly affairs were properly settled.

[2] The Hebrew term יתעפף literally means 'to wrap oneself' or 'to cover oneself,' and specifically refers to the ritual practice of wrapping oneself in a prayer shawl (tallit) with ritual fringes (tzitzit).

[3] These specific numbers are not arbitrary but correspond to the numerical values (gematria) of divine names in Jewish mysticism: 26 equals the value of YHVH (ה-ו-ה-י), 91 represents a combination of divine names, and 112 corresponds to a particular calculation involving all three divine names mentioned.

practice in rabbinic Judaism. The Talmudic text reinforces the idea that confession (vidui) is appropriate for those who are ill or facing death. | Cf. Yoreh De'ah 338-339 — Later halakhic codes systematized the practices mentioned in Ma'avar Yabok, showing how these traditions became normative in Jewish practice. The reference demonstrates that the author is working within an established halakhic framework regarding deathbed practices. | Cf. Masechet Semachot (Evel Rabbati) 1:2 — The author is directly quoting from an authoritative rabbinic source to establish the importance of confession for the dying. By citing this text, he grounds his more mystical and elaborate approach to deathbed rituals in recognized rabbinic tradition.

[i] These specific numbers correspond to the numerical values (gematria) of the divine names mentioned: 26 for YHVH (יהוה), 91 for the combination of YHVH and Adonai when fully spelled out in a specific way, and 112 for the combined value of all three names in a certain calculation method.

[ii] In Kabbalistic thought, different times of day are associated with different divine attributes. Morning is connected to Chesed (Loving-kindness), making it an opportune time for confession as divine mercy is more accessible.

[iii] This refers to a minyan, the quorum of ten Jewish men required for certain religious obligations. Here, the text provides a mystical explanation for this traditional requirement.

ואתיא[i] ובזה אין שם פגע ולא פגע רע:[ii]

remove all accusers from the sick person.[1] And in a place where there is a sick person who is a penitent, the Divine Presence comes before and arrives, and in this case, there is neither adversary nor evil occurrence.[2] 2190R

2040 פרק כ״ד מאמר א׳[iii] טוב לת״ח[iv] להרגיל עצמו לומר תפלה זו ובפרט סמוך לפטירתו:[v]

Chapter 24, First Discourse: It is good for a Torah scholar[3] to accustom himself to reciting this prayer, especially near the time of his death:[4] 2195R

2045 רִבּוֹן עַלְמִין[vi] דְּאַנְתְּ הוּא מָארֵי מַלְכִּין וְגָלֵי רָזִין. יְהֵא רַעֲוָא דֵּילָךְ לְסָבָרָא מִלִּין בְּפוּמָאי:

Master of the Worlds,[A] You who are Lord of kings[B] and revealer of mysteries.[5] May it be Your will to explain words through my mouth,[6] to fulfill in 2200R

[A] Or: "Sovereign of all Realms" — While 'Master of the Worlds' is accurate, 'Sovereign of all Realms' better captures the cosmic scope implied by the Aramaic phrase, which refers to God's dominion across all spiritual dimensions.

[B] Or: "Master of sovereigns" — 'Master of sovereigns' maintains the hierarchical relationship while avoiding the gender-specific 'kings' and emphasizing God's authority over all rulers.

[1] The term מסטין (accusers) derives from the Hebrew root ש-ט-ן (Satan) and refers to spiritual forces that act as prosecutors against a person in the heavenly court. This reflects the Jewish mystical concept that illness can have spiritual causes related to divine judgment.

[2] The phrase "פגע ולא פגע רע" echoes language from Psalm 91, known as the 'Song Against Harmful Occurrences' (שיר של פגעים), which is traditionally recited for protection. The text suggests that genuine repentance creates a spiritual shield around the ill person.

[3] While this instruction is directed specifically at Torah scholars, it reflects the broader theme in Ma'avar Yabok of proper spiritual preparation for death. The author emphasizes certain practices for the learned, with the expectation they would serve as examples for the community.

[4] This phrase connects to Ma'avar Yabok's central purpose of providing guidance for proper spiritual preparation at the end of life. The text suggests that regular recitation of this prayer throughout life, but especially near death, creates spiritual protection for the soul's transition.

[5] This epithet for God ('galei razin') recognizes Him as the source of all mystical knowledge, establishing the author's position that true insight comes through divine revelation rather than human reasoning alone.

[6] The phrase emphasizes the author's view of himself as a channel for divine wisdom rather than its originator, a common expression of humility in kabbalistic writings.

[i] This Aramaic phrase, meaning "the Divine Presence comes before and arrives," is characteristic of Zoharic language. It suggests that the Divine Presence arrives preemptively to protect one who has sincerely repented.

[ii] Cf. Psalms 91 — The text mentions the removal of harmful spiritual forces, which connects to the protective function of Psalm 91, traditionally known as 'shir shel pega'im' (song against harmful occurrences). | Cf. Zohar — The Aramaic phrase 'שכינה קדמא ואתיא' (the Divine Presence comes before and arrives) is characteristic of Zoharic language and reflects the kabbalistic concept that divine protection specially precedes those who have genuinely repented. | Cf. Minyan traditions — The text provides a kabbalistic rationale for the traditional requirement of ten men (minyan) for important rituals, explaining it in terms of the ten sparks of their souls providing spiritual protection for the ill person.

[iii] This heading indicates this is Chapter 24 of the First Discourse (Ma'amar Alef) of Ma'avar Yabok.

[iv] An abbreviation for "Talmid Chacham" (Torah scholar).

[v] The term "petirah" is a euphemism for death, literally meaning "departure." The instruction emphasizes the importance of this prayer specifically when approaching death.

[vi] This prayer begins in Aramaic, the language of the Zohar and many mystical texts, signaling its connection to kabbalistic traditions.

לְקַיֶּמָא בִּי דַּאי קְרָא וְאָנֹכִי אֶהְיֶה עִם פִּיךָ[i] דְּלָא אֵיעוֹל בְּכִסּוּפָּא[ii] קָדָמָךְ וְקָדָם רֵישֵׁי מָתִיבָתָא דִּרְקִיעָא: וְאֶזְכֶּה לְמִשְׁמַע מִלִּין וְרָזִין דְּאוֹרַיְתָא מֵרֵישֵׁי מָתִיבָתֵי עִלָּאֵי:[iii iv]

me this verse, "And I will be with your mouth,"[1] so that I shall not enter with shame before You and before the heads of the heavenly academies.[A] And may I merit to hear words and mysteries of Torah from the heads of the supernal academies.[2]

פרק י״ז מאמר א׳[v] יתבאר קצת מכוונות הודוי ואם תזכור מה שכתבנו בהערת מעירי שחר שלנו[vi] ינוח דעתך בטעם הודוי ולמה הוא באלפא ביתא:[vii viii]

Chapter 17 of the First Discourse will explain some of the intentions behind the confession[3] (vidui) ritual. If you recall what we wrote in our Me'irei Shachar commentary,[4] your mind will be at ease regarding the reason for the confession and why it

[A] Or: "the chief sages of the celestial academies" — This alternate translation more fully conveys the concept of the mystical scholarly institutions believed to exist in the spiritual realms, where departed scholars continue their Torah study.

[1] By invoking God's promise to Moses, the author suggests a parallel between Moses receiving divine guidance for his speech and the author seeking similar assistance in articulating mystical teachings.

[2] The prayer concludes with the desire to receive wisdom directly from the celestial yeshivot, the mystical academies where departed sages continue their Torah studies, suggesting the author seeks knowledge beyond ordinary human understanding.

[3] The Hebrew term 'kavanot' (intentions) has special significance in Kabbalah, referring to specific mystical concentrations or meditations that accompany prayer and ritual. The author is likely referring to these deeper spiritual dimensions of the confession ritual rather than merely its practical aspects.

[4] This work was apparently another text by the same author that contained a more detailed explanation of the mystical significance of the confession ritual. The cross-reference demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok is part of a broader system of religious writings by this author.

[i] A direct quote from Exodus 4:12, where God promises Moses divine assistance with speech. This biblical quotation appears in Hebrew within the otherwise Aramaic prayer.

[ii] The concept of 'entering without shame' (lacking embarrassment) is a recurring theme in kabbalistic literature, referring to the soul's desire to appear properly prepared when facing divine or elevated spiritual entities.

[iii] In kabbalistic tradition, particularly in the Zohar, the 'supernal academies' are where souls of righteous scholars continue studying Torah after death, headed by great sages of previous generations.

[iv] Cf. Exodus 4:12 — The author is invoking God's promise to Moses as a request for divine assistance in articulating spiritual wisdom, positioning himself as a vessel for divine communication like Moses. | Cf. Zohar — The author draws on Zoharic concepts of heavenly academies presided over by great sages, expressing hope to receive wisdom from these exalted sources rather than relying solely on his own understanding. | Cf. Daniel 2:28 — By using this phrase from Daniel, the author acknowledges God as the ultimate source of mystical knowledge, positioning himself as a recipient rather than originator of spiritual insights.

[v] This indicates 'Chapter 17 of the First Discourse' of Ma'avar Yabok.

[vi] Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) appears to be another work by the same author, likely a prayer book or collection. It shares its name with a prayer society in Modena that gathered for morning prayers, as mentioned elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok.

[vii] Many traditional Jewish confession prayers are structured alphabetically, with each sin or phrase beginning with successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet. This provides a comprehensive framework and aids memory.

[viii] Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author is directing readers to consult his other work for a more comprehensive explanation of the confession ritual and its structure, suggesting a systematic approach to his religious writings across multiple texts. | Cf. Alphabetical confession prayers — Many traditional Jewish confession prayers, including the Yom Kippur 'Al Chet' confession, are structured

follows alphabetical order.[A 1]

ועיקר ודוי ש״מ[i] צריך שיאמר ע״י סרסור[ii] כנתבאר פי״ט מאמר א׳:[iii] יתחיל ויאמר מזמור בקראי ענני סימן ד׳[iv] ויפתח בשבירות לב על עונותיו:[v vi]

The essential confession for a deathly ill person[B] must be said through an intermediary[C] as explained in Chapter 19 of the First Discourse: he should begin by reciting Psalm 4[2] (“Answer me when I call”) and commence with a broken heart[D] regarding his sins.[3]

(תהלים ד) לַמְנַצֵּחַ בִּנְגִינוֹת מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד: בְּקָרְאִי עֲנֵנִי אֱלֹהֵי

For the Chief Musician, with stringed instruments.[4] A Psalm of David. Answer me when I

[A] Or: “according to the alef-bet” — Using ‘alef-bet’ instead of ‘alphabetical order’ preserves the Hebrew terminology for the alphabet, which might be preferable in a scholarly translation that aims to maintain cultural specificity.

[B] Or: “one who is terminally ill” — The abbreviation ש״מ (shechiv mera) refers to someone gravely ill and near death. ‘Terminally ill’ better conveys this medical state in modern English, while ‘deathly ill person’ is more literal but less precise.

[C] Or: “through a mediator” — The term ‘סרסור’ (sarsor) refers to someone who facilitates between parties. While ‘intermediary’ is accurate, ‘mediator’ might better convey the role of guiding the confession process.

[D] Or: “with contrition” — While ‘broken heart’ is the literal translation, ‘contrition’ might better capture the religious concept of remorse for sins in this context of confession.

[1] The alphabetical structure of confession prayers has both practical and mystical significance in Jewish tradition. Practically, it helps ensure comprehensiveness (covering sins ‘from A to Z’). Mystically, it is believed to access all spiritual channels represented by the Hebrew letters, which in Kabbalah are considered building blocks of creation.

[2] Psalm 4 begins with a plea for divine attention (“Answer me when I call”) and includes themes of being set apart by God, finding peace, and trust in divine protection—all appropriate themes for someone facing death.

[3] Jewish tradition emphasizes that confession (vidui) must be accompanied by genuine remorse rather than merely reciting formulaic words. This emotional state was considered crucial for effective spiritual preparation for death.

[4] These musical notations at the beginning of the psalm suggest it was originally meant for public worship with instrumental accompaniment. In Ma’avar Yabok, it serves as part of a private devotional sequence for the sick or dying.

in alphabetical order, with each sin or phrase beginning with successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet. The author is explaining the reasoning behind this structure, which he apparently discussed more fully in his other work.

[i] The abbreviation ש״מ stands for שביב מרע (shechiv mera), a legal term in Jewish law referring to someone who is gravely ill and presumed to be on their deathbed.

[ii] The word סרסור (sarsor) literally means “agent” or “broker” but in this context refers to someone who assists the dying person with their confession, possibly because the ill person might be too weak to recite the full confession themselves.

[iii] This is a cross-reference to Chapter 19 of the First Discourse of Ma’avar Yabok, where the author previously explained this practice in detail.

[iv] This refers to Psalm 4, which begins with “Answer me when I call” (בְּקָרְאִי עֲנֵנִי). The term סימן ד׳ simply means “number 4,” identifying the psalm.

[v] This phrase emphasizes the importance of genuine contrition during confession. It’s not merely a ritual recitation but requires sincere remorse for one’s sins.

[vi] Cf. Masechet Semachot — Ma’avar Yabok draws on this minor tractate (also called Evel Rabbati) for its guidance on deathbed confession practices, showing how the text grounds its instructions in established rabbinic literature. | Cf. Psalm 4 — The instruction to begin with this psalm suggests it was considered particularly appropriate for deathbed confession, likely because it contains themes of divine mercy and protection that would comfort someone facing death. | Cf. Chapter 19, First Discourse of Ma’avar Yabok — The author’s cross-reference to an earlier section of Ma’avar Yabok shows the book’s systematic organization as a reference manual, with different sections elaborating on various aspects of deathbed practices.

צִדְקִי[i] בַּצָּר הִרְחַבְתָּ לִּי חָנֵּנִי וּשְׁמַע
תְּפִלָּתִי: בְּנֵי אִישׁ עַד מָה כְּבוֹדִי
לְכְלִמָּה תְּאֳהֲבוּן רִיק תְּבַקְשׁוּ כָזָב
סֶלָה: וּדְעוּ כִּי הִפְלָה יְיָ חָסִיד
לוֹ יְיָ יִשְׁמַע בְּקָרְאִי אֵלָיו: רִגְזוּ
וְאַל תֶּחֱטָאוּ אִמְרוּ בִלְבַבְכֶם עַל
מִשְׁכַּבְכֶם[ii] וְדֹמּוּ סֶלָה: זִבְחוּ זִבְחֵי
צֶדֶק וּבִטְחוּ אֶל יְיָ: רַבִּים אֹמְרִים
מִי יַרְאֵנוּ טוֹב נְסָה עָלֵינוּ אוֹר
פָּנֶיךָ יְיָ: נָתַתָּה שִׂמְחָה בְלִבִּי מֵעֵת
דְּגָנָם וְתִירוֹשָׁם רָבּוּ: בְּשָׁלוֹם יַחְדָּו
אֶשְׁכְּבָה וְאִישָׁן[iii] כִּי אַתָּה יְיָ לְבָדָד
לָבֶטַח תּוֹשִׁיבֵנִי:[iv]

call, O God of my righteousness! You have relieved me in my distress; be gracious to me and hear my prayer. O sons of men,[A] how long shall my glory be turned to shame? How long will you love emptiness and seek falsehood? Selah. But know that the LORD has set apart the godly for Himself;[B] the LORD will hear when I call to Him. Be angry, and do not sin;[C] meditate in your hearts upon your beds, and be silent. Selah. Offer sacrifices of righteousness,[1] and trust in the LORD. Many are saying, "Who will show us any good?" Lift up the light of Your countenance upon us, O LORD! You have put gladness in my heart, more than when their grain and new wine abound. In peace I will both lie down and sleep,[2] for You alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety.

[A] Or: "Men of rank" — The Hebrew phrase 'bnei ish' can specifically refer to men of importance or high rank, as opposed to ordinary people. In the context of the psalm, David may be addressing those in positions of power who are turning against him.

[B] Or: "His faithful one" — The singular form 'chasid' (devout/faithful one) with the possessive 'lo' (for Himself) could be translated in the singular rather than the plural, suggesting that God sets apart each faithful person individually.

[C] Or: "Tremble and do not sin" — The Hebrew 'rigzu' can mean 'tremble' or 'be disturbed/agitated' rather than specifically 'be angry.' This interpretation suggests reverent fear rather than mere anger, which fits the religious context better.

[1] In the post-Temple era when Ma'avar Yabok was written, 'sacrifices of righteousness' would be understood as prayer, repentance, and charitable deeds—precisely the spiritual practices recommended for those approaching death.

[2] The psalm's conclusion expresses profound trust in divine protection, making it particularly appropriate for the sick or dying who seek similar peace in their vulnerable state. The confidence in safe repose under divine care reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation for death.

[i] The direct appeal to God as "my righteousness" is significant in the context of illness and approaching death, as it expresses confidence in divine justice even when physical circumstances suggest abandonment.

[ii] The phrase "speak in your hearts upon your beds" has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context, as it refers to the practice of self-examination and confession while bedridden—precisely the situation of those who are ill or dying.

[iii] The language of peaceful sleep serves as a euphemism for death in many biblical contexts. In a prayer recited as part of deathbed confessions, this would have dual meaning—both literal sleep and the final sleep of death.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 3:5 — Both Psalm 3:5 and Psalm 4:8 conclude with expressions of peaceful rest despite distress, suggesting that Psalm 4 may have been composed as an evening prayer for the sick or dying person. The mention of lying down in peace would be particularly comforting in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences for the ill. | Cf. Ephesians 4:26 — The New Testament quotes Psalm 4:4, suggesting this psalm's relevance to spiritual reconciliation and inner peace before sleep. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this would be meaningful for encouraging the sick person to resolve emotional and spiritual conflicts before the possibility of death. | Cf. Zohar III:204b — The Zohar connects Psalm 4:4 ('meditate in your hearts upon your beds') to the practice of examining one's conscience before sleep, which parallels Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession and spiritual preparation before death. The psalm's inclusion in deathbed prayers suggests this connection between nightly spiritual accounting and final preparation.

אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי תָּבֹא לְפָנֶיךָ
תְּפִלָּתִי וְאַל תִּתְעַלַּם מִתְּחִנָּתִי
שֶׁאֵין אֲנִי עַז פָּנִים וּקְשֵׁה עֹרֶף
(ואם היא אשה תאמר שֶׁאֵין אֲנַחְנוּ
עַזּוֹת פָּנִים וּקְשֵׁות עֹרֶף וכן בכל
מקום שיצטרך)[i] בְּדָבָר הַזֶּה
שֶׁאֹמַר לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי
אֲבוֹתַי צַדִּיק אֲנִי וְלֹא חָטָאתִי
אֲבָל חָטָאתִי עָוִיתִי פָּרַדְתִּי אֲנִי
וַאֲבוֹתַי: אָשַׁמְתִּי. אָבַלְתִּי דְּבָרִים
אֲסוּרִים וּמְתוּעָבִים:[ii] בָּגַדְתִּי.
בִּטֵּטִתִּי בִּשְׂפָתַי: גָּזָלְתִּי. גָּבַהּ לִבִּי
רָמוּ עֵינַי: הִדַּרְתִּי הִכְּפִי וּדְבָרִים
בְּטֵלִים: הֶעֱוִיתִי. הוֹצֵאתִי דִּבָּה
וְשִׁכְבַת זֶרַע לְבַטָּלָה: וְהִרְשַׁעְתִּי
בְּוִיעוּד עֲבֵרָה וּבְהֶרְהוּר רָעָה:
זַדְתִּי. וָנִיתִי זְלַזָּלְתִּי מוֹרִים
וְהוֹרִים: חָמַסְתִּי. חִלַּלְתִּי שֵׁם
יְיָ בַּסֵּתֶר וּבַגָּלוּי. חִלַּלְתִּי
שַׁבָּתוֹת וְיָמִים טוֹבִים: טָפַלְתִּי
שֶׁקֶר. טִמֵּאתִי רַעְיוֹנַי בְּמַחֲשָׁבוֹת
וּבְהֶרְהוּרִים אֲסוּרִים. טִמֵּאתִי
בְּרִית קֹדֶשׁ: יָעַצְתִּי רָע. יִהַרְתִּי
בְּתוֹרָתְךָ:[iii] כִּזַּבְתִּי. כָּנַסְתִּי
כְּנֵסִיוֹת שֶׁלֹּא לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם: לַצְתִּי
לְשׁוֹנִי: הִמְרֵתִי. מָרַדְתִּי. מָרִיתִי
בְּמַשָּׂא וּבְמַתָּן: נָאַפְתִּי.

My God and God of my fathers,[A] may my prayer come before You, and do not ignore my supplication, for I am not brazen-faced or stiff-necked (and if she is a woman, she should say: for I am not brazen-faced or stiff-necked, and so in every place where necessary) to say before You, LORD my God and God of my fathers, that I am righteous and have not sinned. Rather, I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled, I and my fathers:

I have become guilty. I have eaten forbidden and abominable things.[1] I have betrayed. I have spoken rashly with my lips. I have stolen. My heart has become haughty and my eyes proud. I have spoken slander and idle words. I have perverted. I have spread malicious gossip and emitted seed in vain. I have acted wickedly in planning sin and in evil thoughts. I have acted deliberately. I have committed fornication and disrespected teachers and parents. I have extorted. I have profaned the name of the LORD in private and in public. I have desecrated Sabbaths and holy days. I have attributed falsehood. I have defiled my thoughts with forbidden ideas and impulses. I have defiled the holy covenant.[B] I have given evil advice. I have been arrogant regarding Your Torah. I have lied. I have convened gatherings not for the sake of Heaven. I have used my tongue for mockery.[2] I have rebelled. I have acted treach-

[A] Or: "My God and God of my ancestors" — A gender-neutral translation of 'avotai' as 'ancestors' rather than 'fathers' would be more inclusive for contemporary readers, especially since the prayer includes instructions for female worshippers. This option maintains the theological content while using more inclusive language.

[B] Or: "I have defiled the covenant of circumcision" — In rabbinic literature, 'brit kodesh' often specifically refers to circumcision, which is considered a physical sign of the covenant between God and the Jewish people. This more specific translation clarifies the nature of this particular transgression, which likely refers to sexual impropriety.

[1] The Hebrew confession follows an alphabetical acrostic pattern, with each series of confessions beginning with successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet. This literary device, common in Jewish liturgical texts, serves both as a memory aid and as a way to suggest comprehensiveness—covering sins 'from A to Z.'

[2] The Hebrew letter ל (lamed) begins this confession, but in the next line, the text moves to מ (mem), skipping the expected progression. This irregularity may indicate textual corruption

[i] This parenthetical instruction indicates that the confession text provides gender-specific variations for women, demonstrating the author's attention to making the prayer accessible to all. Such gender-specific liturgical instructions were relatively progressive for their time.

[ii] The confession follows a quasi-alphabetical structure, with each line beginning with successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet. This format follows traditional Jewish confessional prayers like the Yom Kippur 'Al Chet' and serves as a comprehensive framework to ensure no type of sin is overlooked.

[iii] The term 'יִהַרְתִּי' (yiharti) likely means 'I have been arrogant/presumptuous,' particularly in relation to Torah learning. This reflects the Jewish concept that true Torah study requires humility.

נָשָׂאתִי בְגָשֶׁךְ וְתַרְבִּית: סָרַרְתִּי.
סָקַרְתִּי עָיִן: עָוִיתִי. הֵעַזְתִּי
מָצַח: פָּשַׁעְתִּי. פָּרַקְתִּי עוֹל תּוֹרָה
וְיִרְאַת שָׁמַיִם: צָרַרְתִּי. צָחַנְתִּי
מַעֲשָׂי: קִשֵּׁיתִי עֹרֶף. קִלְקַלְתִּי
פְּעוּלוֹתַי. קָפַצְתִּי יָדִי מֵאָחִי
הָאֶבְיוֹן: רָשַׁעְתִּי. רָכַלְתִּי עַל רֵעַ
וְעָמִית. רַגְלַי הִרְצִיתִי לְרָעָה:
שִׁחַתִּי. שָׁנֵאתִי שֹׂנְאַת חִנָּם: תָּעִיתִי.
וְכָפַרְתִּי תְּשׁוּמֶת יָד:[i] תִּעְתָּעְתִּי.
תּוֹעֵבָה וְתוֹעֵבָה עָשִׂיתִי: סַרְתִּי
מִמִּצְוֹתֶיךָ וּמִמִּשְׁפָּטֶיךָ הַטּוֹבִים
וְלֹא שָׁוָה לִי: וְאַתָּה צַדִּיק עַל
כָּל הַבָּא עָלַי כִּי אֱמֶת עָשִׂיתָ
וַאֲנִי הִרְשַׁעְתִּי.[ii] מָה אֹמַר לְפָנֶיךָ
יוֹשֵׁב מָרוֹם וּמָה אֲסַפֵּר לְפָנֶיךָ
שׁוֹכֵן שְׁחָקִים הֲלֹא כָּל הַנִּסְתָּרוֹת
וְהַנִּגְלוֹת אַתָּה יוֹדֵעַ: אַתָּה יוֹדֵעַ
רָזֵי עוֹלָם וְתַעֲלוּמוֹת סִתְרֵי כָּל
חָי אַתָּה חוֹפֵשׂ כָּל חַדְרֵי בָטֶן
וּבוֹחֵן כְּלָיוֹת וָלֵב אֵין כָּל דָּבָר
נֶעְלָם מִמֶּךָּ וְאֵין נִסְתָּר מִנֶּגֶד
עֵינֶיךָ: יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ
אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי שֶׁתִּסְלַח
וְתִמְחַל לִי בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים עַל
כָּל עֲוֹנוֹתַי וּפְשָׁעַי וּתְכַפֵּר לִי עַל
כָּל חַטֹּאתַי:[iii]

erously. I have been dishonest in business dealings. I have blasphemed. I have committed adultery. I have taken interest and excessive profit. I have been stubborn. I have looked lustfully.[A] I have transgressed. I have been brazen-faced. I have willfully sinned. I have cast off the yoke of Torah and fear of Heaven.[1] I have caused trouble. My actions have become offensive. I have been stiff-necked. I have corrupted my deeds. I have closed my hand from my needy brother. I have acted wickedly. I have gossiped about friends and colleagues. I have directed my feet toward evil. I have corrupted. I have hated without cause. I have gone astray. I have denied objects entrusted to me. I have led others astray. I have wandered and committed abominations.

I have turned aside from Your commandments and from Your good judgments, and it has not profited me. And You are righteous concerning all that has come upon me, for You have acted truthfully, while I have acted wickedly.[2] What can I say before You, Who dwells on high, and what can I relate before You, Who resides in the heavens? Do You not know all things hidden and revealed? You know the secrets of the universe and the hidden mysteries of all living beings. You search all the chambers of the body and examine the heart and mind. Nothing is hidden from You, and nothing is concealed from

[A] Or: "I have cast covetous glances" — The Hebrew phrase refers to improper gazing or looking, particularly with sexual intent. 'Cast covetous glances' might better capture the specific impropriety of looking at what is forbidden to desire.

or deliberate composition choice, which is not uncommon in alphabetical acrostics in Hebrew literature.

[1] The metaphor of 'casting off the yoke' (פָּרַקְתִּי עוֹל) draws from agricultural imagery where an animal removes the yoke that directs its labor. This powerful metaphor appears frequently in rabbinic literature to describe rejection of divine authority.

[2] This contrast between divine truth and human wickedness reflects a fundamental theological concept in Judaism that even in confessing sin, one affirms God's justice. This represents the concept of 'tzidduk ha-din' (justification of divine judgment), which is particularly emphasized in contexts of illness and death.

[i] This phrase refers to denying a deposit or loan, a specific transgression mentioned in Leviticus 5:21-26. Including such specific legal infractions alongside general moral failings shows how this confession integrates ritual, ethical, and interpersonal dimensions of Jewish law.

[ii] This line echoes Nehemiah 9:33, acknowledging divine justice in all circumstances. This theological affirmation of divine righteousness even in suffering is a core element of traditional Jewish confession (vidui).

[iii] Cf. Yom Kippur Vidui — This confession in Ma'avar Yabok draws from and expands upon the traditional Yom Kippur confessional prayers, adapting them specifically for deathbed recitation. The alphabetical structure and many of the specific sins mentioned parallel the liturgical Yom Kippur confessions, showing how Ma'avar Yabok adapts established liturgical forms for end-of-life contexts. | Cf. Leviticus — The specific mention of 'teshument yad' (deposit) directly references

Your sight. May it be Your will, LORD my God and God of my fathers, that You forgive and pardon me in Your abundant mercy for all my iniquities and transgressions, and that You atone for all my sins.[1] 2290R

אח״כ[i] יאמר עם המתודה:[ii][iii] After this, one shall say with the person making confession:[A]

רִבּוֹן כָּל הָעוֹלָמִים גָּלוּי וְיָדוּעַ לִפְנֵי כִסֵּא כְבוֹדֶךָ שֶׁרְפוּאָתִי בְיָדֶךָ וּמִיתָתִי בְּיָדֶךָ: יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי שֶׁלֹּא אָמוּת מַחֲלִי זֶה ג׳ פְּעָמִים:[iv] (וְטוֹב שֶׁיֹּאמַר שֶׁלֹּא אָמוּת בְּבַת אַחַת וְלֹא יָשִׂים רְיוַח בֵּינֵיהֶם)[v] וְתִסְעָדֵנִי כַּאֲשֶׁר סָעַדְתָּ חִזְקִיָּה מֶלֶךְ יְהוּדָה בְּחָלְיוֹ וּמַדַּלָּה תְּבַצְּעֵנִי. וּמִיּוֹם עַד לָיְלָה תַּשְׁלִימֵנִי. וּבְכַף זְכוּת

Master of all the worlds, it is revealed and known before Your throne of glory that my healing is in Your hand and my death is in Your hand. May it be Your will, LORD my God and God of my fathers, that I shall not die from this illness [to be said three times]. (It is good to say "that I shall not die" in one breath without pausing between repetitions.) Sustain me as You sustained Hezekiah, king of Judah, in his illness,[2] and rescue me from poverty.[B] Complete me from day until night.[C] Weigh me and judge me in the 2295R 2300R

[A] Or: "Then he shall recite together with the one confessing:" — This is a more direct translation that emphasizes the joint recitation aspect, which might be clearer in some contexts.

[B] Or: "and cut me off from affliction" — The Hebrew word 'וּמַדַּלָּה' can be understood as 'cut off/separate' rather than 'rescue,' and 'דַּלָּה' can refer to affliction or lowliness rather than strictly poverty. This alternative reflects a plea to be separated from one's suffering rather than specifically from poverty.

[C] Or: "From day until night You will make an end of me" — This phrase from Isaiah 38:12-13 can alternatively be understood as God bringing the person's life to completion within a day (from morning to night), reflecting the brevity of life when facing mortality. This interpretation aligns with Hezekiah's lament about God ending his life.

[1] The Hebrew uses three distinct terms for wrongdoing: 'avonot' (iniquities), 'pesha'im' (transgressions/rebellious acts), and 'chata'im' (sins/errors). This tripartite classification of wrongdoing is traditional in Jewish thought, distinguishing between unintentional errors, willful violations, and rebellious acts against divine authority.

[2] This references the biblical account in 2 Kings 20 and Isaiah 38 where King Hezekiah fell mortally ill but was granted healing and fifteen additional years of life after his prayer to God. This story serves as a powerful precedent for divine healing in Jewish tradition.

the biblical laws in Leviticus regarding misappropriation of entrusted property, showing how this confession integrates specific legal infractions from Torah alongside general moral failings. | Cf. Nehemiah — The phrase 'You are righteous concerning all that has come upon me, for You have acted truthfully, while I have acted wickedly' echoes Nehemiah's communal confession. This shows how Ma'avar Yabok incorporates biblical confessional language, particularly the theological affirmation of divine justice even in suffering.

[i] This abbreviation stands for 'achar kach' (after this/afterward) and is a common liturgical instruction marking the sequence of prayer recitation.

[ii] From the root 'vidui' (confession), this term specifically refers to the sick or dying person who is reciting the deathbed confession, a central ritual in Jewish preparation for death.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This brief liturgical instruction serves as a transition between the explanation of confession practices and the actual prayer text that follows. It indicates that the prayer leader should recite the following confession together with the sick or dying person, emphasizing the communal aspect of the deathbed ritual.

[iv] The instruction is to repeat the phrase "that I shall not die from this illness" three times, a common practice in Jewish prayers where certain phrases are repeated three times for emphasis.

[v] This parenthetical note provides specific instructions on how to recite the previous phrase—without pausing between repetitions, emphasizing the urgency and continuity of the prayer.

תְּשַׁקְּלֵנִי וּתְדִינֵנִי. וּבְאוֹרְךָ הַגָּדוֹל
תְּאִירֵנִי. וְאִם בַּר מִינָן וְחַס
וְשָׁלוֹם אָמוּת[i] (יש מדקדקים
שלא לומר בר מינן וחס ושלום
ובנוסח הרמב״ן הכתוב בפרק
ט׳ איתיה)[ii] תְּהֵא גוּפִי מְזֻבָּח
כַּפָּרָה וְנַפְשִׁי קָרְבַּן טַהֲרָה וּמִיתָתִי
תְּהֵיֶה סְלִיחָה וּמְחִילָה וְכַפָּרָה
עַל כָּל חַטֹּאתַי וַעֲוֹנוֹתַי וּפְשָׁעַי
שֶׁחָטָאתִי וְשֶׁעָוִיתִי וְשֶׁפָּשַׁעְתִּי
לְפָנֶיךָ מִיּוֹם הֱיוֹתִי עַד הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה
וְתֵן חֶלְקִי עִם הַצַּדִּיקִים לאשה
(הַצַּדָּקָנִיּוֹת)[iii] בְּגַן עֵדֶן וְזַכֵּנִי
לְעוֹלָם הַבָּא הַצָּפוּן לַצַּדִּיקִים
וּמַעֲדָנֶיךָ תַּשְׂבִּיעֵנִי וְיִתְקַדֵּשׁ שִׁמְךָ
הַגָּדוֹל עַל יָדִי בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה
וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא סֶלָה וָעֶד: תּוֹדִיעֵנִי
אֹרַח חַיִּים שִׂבַע שְׂמָחוֹת אֶת פָּנֶיךָ
נְעִימוֹת בִּימִינְךָ נֶצַח: וְיָדַעְתָּ
הַיּוֹם וַהֲשֵׁבוֹתָ אֶל לְבָבֶךָ כִּי יְיָ
הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים בַּשָּׁמַיִם מִמַּעַל וְעַל
הָאָרֶץ מִתָּחַת אֵין עוֹד: יְיָ אֱלֹהִים
אֱמֶת וּמֹשֶׁה אֱמֶת וְתוֹרָתוֹ אֱמֶת (ג׳
פעמים):[iv] מַלְכֵּנוּ וֵאלֹהֵינוּ יַחַד
שִׁמְךָ בְּעוֹלָמֶךָ עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ:
עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן יְמִינֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן
תּוֹרָתֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן קְדֻשָּׁתֶךָ:
עָזְרֵנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ עַל דְּבַר כְּבוֹד
שְׁמֶךָ שֶׁיִּתְקַדֵּשׁ וְיִתְיַחֵד עַל יָדֵינוּ
לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד: וְהַצִּילֵנוּ וְכַפֵּר
עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ: שְׁמַע
יִשְׂרָאֵל יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְיָ אֶחָד: בָּרוּךְ

scale of merit. Illuminate me with Your great light. 2305R
And if, God forbid, I should die (some are careful not
to say "God forbid" and in Ramban's version written
in Chapter 9, it appears differently), may my body
be an altar of atonement,[1] my soul an offering of
purification, and may my death be forgiveness, par- 2310R
don, and atonement for all my sins, iniquities, and
transgressions that I have sinned, transgressed, and
rebelled before You from the day of my existence
until this day. Grant my portion with the righteous
[for a woman: (the righteous women)] in the Garden 2315R
of Eden, and privilege me to the World to Come
that is reserved for the righteous. Satisfy me with
Your delights, and may Your great name be sancti-
fied through me in this world and in the World to
Come, selah and forever. Make known to me the 2320R
path of life;[2] in Your presence is fullness of joy; at
Your right hand are pleasures forevermore. And you
shall know today and take to heart that the LORD is
God in heaven above and on the earth below; there
is none else. The LORD God is truth, and Moses is 2325R
truth, and His Torah is truth [three times]. Our King
and our God, unify Your name in Your world. Act for
the sake of Your name; act for the sake of Your right
hand; act for the sake of Your Torah; act for the sake
of Your holiness. Help us, O God of our salvation, 2330R
for the glory of Your name, that it may be sanctified
and unified through us forever and ever. Deliver us
and atone for our sins for the sake of Your name.
Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is
One.[3] Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom 2335R
forever and ever. Blessed is the LORD of Hosts, our

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the suffering of illness and death can serve as atonement for sins, transforming the physical body into a metaphorical sacrificial altar that purifies the soul.
[2] This begins a direct quotation from Psalm 16:11, which continues with "in Your presence is fullness of joy; at Your right hand are pleasures forevermore." This verse is traditionally associated with the afterlife and divine reward.
[3] This is the Shema, the central declaration of Jewish faith from Deuteronomy 6:4. Reciting the Shema is particularly significant for someone approaching death, as it is traditionally the final prayer a Jewish person should say before dying.

[i] The phrase "bar minan" (literally "separate from us") is a euphemistic way of referring to death, similar to saying "God forbid" in English.
[ii] This parenthetical note indicates that some are careful not to use the euphemism "bar minan" when talking about one's own death, and references that Ramban's (Nachmanides) version of this prayer in Chapter 9 of the work includes this phrase differently.
[iii] This indicates a textual variation for women, who should substitute "the righteous women" instead of "the righteous" (men), showing the prayer's adaptability for different genders.
[iv] The instruction indicates that the phrase "The LORD God is truth, and Moses is truth, and His Torah is truth" should be repeated three times, which is a common liturgical pattern in Jewish prayers.

שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:
בָּרוּךְ יְיָ צְבָאוֹת אֱלֹהֵינוּ שֶׁבְּרָאָנוּ
לִכְבוֹדוֹ וּבָרוּךְ אֵל אֱלֵים וֵאלֹהֵי
הָאֱלֹהִים וּמֶלֶךְ עוֹלָם: יְיָ הוּא
הָאֱלֹהִים יְיָ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים: מְיוּחָד
אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה הוּא הָיָה וְהוּא
הֹוֶה וְהוּא יִהְיֶה: הוּא מֵמִית וּמְחַיֶּה
לְפָנָיו לֹא נוֹצַר אֵל וְאַחֲרָיו לֹא
יִהְיֶה: יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת: יְיָ מֶלֶךְ יְיָ מָלָךְ
יְיָ יִמְלֹךְ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד: וְהָיָה יְיָ
לְמֶלֶךְ עַל כָּל הָאָרֶץ בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא
יִהְיֶה יְיָ אֶחָד וּשְׁמוֹ אֶחָד: בָּרוּךְ
יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל מֵהָעוֹלָם וְעַד
הָעוֹלָם אָמֵן וְאָמֵן:
[i]

God who created us for His glory, and blessed is the God of gods and the God of gods and King of the universe. The LORD, He is God; the LORD, He is God.[1] The unique "I Am That I Am,"[2] He was, He is, and He will be. He causes death and brings to life; before Him no god was formed, and after Him there shall be none. The LORD is God of truth. The LORD reigns, the LORD has reigned, the LORD will reign forever and ever. And the LORD shall be King over all the earth; on that day the LORD shall be One and His name One. Blessed is the LORD, God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting. Amen and Amen.

אם דעת החולה מיושבת
עליו[ii] קודם הרבון הנ"ל[iii] יוסיף
על חטא וגומר[iv] עד עושה שלום
במרומיו וגו'[v]:
[vi]

If the sick person is mentally sound,[A] before the aforementioned prayer "Ribon" [Master of the Universe], he should add the "Al Chet" [confession of sins] and continue[B] until "Oseh Shalom Bimro-

[A] Or: "If the sick person is lucid and coherent" — This alternate translation emphasizes the cognitive clarity needed for the full confession ritual, which might be preferable in contexts where the modern medical understanding of mental competence is being emphasized.

[B] Or: "the complete Yom Kippur confession beginning with "Al Chet"" — This alternate trans-

[1] This phrase repeats the declaration from 1 Kings 18:39, which was the response of the Israelites after Elijah's contest with the prophets of Baal, and has become a powerful affirmation of monotheism in Jewish tradition.

[2] This references God's self-revelation to Moses at the burning bush in Exodus 3:14, where God identifies Himself as "Ehyeh Asher Ehyeh" (I Am That I Am), understood in Jewish mysticism as expressing God's eternal and unchanging nature.

[i] Cf. Isaiah 38 — This prayer explicitly references Hezekiah's healing as a precedent, invoking the biblical account as a paradigm for divine healing in response to sincere prayer. | Cf. Psalm 16:11 — The psalm verse is quoted to express hope for divine guidance after death, suggesting that even if physical healing doesn't occur, the soul will find its path to eternal joy in God's presence. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok Chapter 9 — The text references an alternative version of this prayer attributed to Ramban found elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok, indicating that this prayer exists in multiple versions with slight variations. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4 — The inclusion of the Shema prayer indicates this text is meant for someone potentially approaching death, as Jewish tradition prescribes reciting the Shema as one's final words.

[ii] This phrase literally means "if the sick person's mind is settled upon him," which refers to mental clarity or soundness of mind, indicating that the person is cognitively able to engage in the confession ritual.

[iii] "Ha-Ribon ha-nizkar le'eil" refers to "the Master [prayer] mentioned above," indicating a prayer beginning with "Ribon" (Master of the Universe) that was referenced earlier in the text.

[iv] "Al Chet ve-gomer" refers to the "Al Chet" confession prayer recited on Yom Kippur, which begins with "For the sin" and systematically lists various categories of sins. "Ve-gomer" (etc.) indicates that the full, well-known prayer should be recited.

[v] "Oseh Shalom Bimromav ve-go'" refers to the concluding prayer "He who makes peace in His high places," which typically ends many Jewish prayers, including the Kaddish. The abbreviation "ve-go'" (etc.) indicates that the rest of this familiar prayer formula should be recited.

[vi] Cf. Yom Kippur liturgy — The adaptation of Yom Kippur liturgy for deathbed confession shows how death was viewed as a moment of ultimate judgment similar to Yom Kippur, with the confession serving a similar purpose of spiritual purification before facing divine judgment. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This instruction is part of Ma'avar Yabok's systematic approach to deathbed

mav”[1] [He who makes peace in His high places], etc. 2355R

עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי לְפָנֶיךָ בְּאֹנֶס:
עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי לְפָנֶיךָ בִּרְצוֹן:
2195 עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי לְפָנֶיךָ בְּמֵזִיד:
עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי לְפָנֶיךָ בִּנְגְלָה:
עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי לְפָנֶיךָ בְּיוֹדֵעַ
וּבְלֹא יוֹדֵעַ: עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי
לְפָנֶיךָ בְּרַמַ״ח אֵבָרַי וְשַׁסַ״ה
2200 גִידַי וְעוֹרְקַי:[i] עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי
לְפָנֶיךָ בְּרַמַ״ח אֵבָרַי וְשַׁסַ״ה גִידַי
וְעוֹרְקַי נַפְשִׁי: עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי
לְפָנֶיךָ בְּרַמַ״ח אֵבָרַי וְשַׁסַ״ה גִידַי
וְעוֹרְקַי רוּחִי: עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי
2205 לְפָנֶיךָ בְּרַמַ״ח אֵבָרַי וְשַׁסַ״ה
גִידַי וְעוֹרְקַי נִשְׁמָתִי: וְכֵן בְּמָה
שֶׁגָּרַמְתִּי לַאֲחֵרִים הַכֹּל תֵּעָבִיר
וְתִמְחֹל וְתִסְלַח אֲשֶׁר נוֹאַלְנוּ וַאֲשֶׁר
חָטָאנוּ בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים וּבַחֲסָדֶיךָ
2210 הַגְּדוֹלִים וּבְכֹחָם הַמְאִירִים
לָאָרֶץ וְלַדָּרִים בְּסוֹד שְׁלֹשׁ עֶשְׂרֵה
מִדּוֹתֶיךָ[ii] אֲשֶׁר הִפְקַדְתָּם עַל

For the sin that I have sinned before You under compulsion;[2] for the sin that I have sinned before You willingly; for the sin that I have sinned before You deliberately; for the sin that I have sinned before You openly; for the sin that I have sinned before You knowingly and unknowingly; for the sin that I have sinned before You with my 248 limbs and 365 sinews and veins; for the sin that I have sinned before You with the 248 limbs and 365 sinews and veins of my nefesh (vital soul); for the sin that I have sinned before You with the 248 limbs and 365 sinews and veins of my ruach (spirit); for the sin that I have sinned before You with the 248 limbs and 365 sinews and veins of my neshamah (higher soul);[3] and likewise for what I have caused others to do[A]—may You remove all, pardon and forgive that which we have done foolishly and that which we have sinned, through Your abundant mercies and Your great kindnesses,[B] and through their illuminating power to the earth and its inhabitants, through the mystery of Your Thirteen 2360R 2365R 2370R 2375R

lation more explicitly connects the prayer to its Yom Kippur origins, which might be helpful for readers less familiar with Jewish liturgy.

[A] Or: “and likewise for what I have caused others [to sin]” — The Hebrew phrase is somewhat ambiguous and could specifically refer to causing others to sin, which is considered particularly serious in Jewish tradition. This alternate translation makes this implication more explicit.

[B] Or: “through Your abundant compassion and Your great loving-kindness” — This alternate translation uses theological terms (‘compassion’ and ‘loving-kindness’) that more closely align with traditional English renderings of the Hebrew theological concepts of ‘rachamim’ and ‘chesed’.

[1] This prayer formula concludes many Jewish prayers, including the Kaddish. Its inclusion here shows how the deathbed confession was structured to follow established prayer patterns familiar to the dying person and those attending them.

[2] This confession begins by acknowledging sins committed under various states of consciousness and volition, moving from least culpable (under compulsion) to most culpable (deliberately, openly).

[3] The repetitive structure of this confession creates a comprehensive accounting of sin affecting every aspect of one’s being. The confession systematically addresses sins committed through one’s physical body and through all levels of the soul, creating a complete spiritual inventory.

rituals, offering a complete liturgical framework with options based on the sick person’s condition. The text creates a hierarchy of confession options, with this being the most complete version for those capable of full participation.

[i] The Hebrew text uses abbreviations with quotation marks: רַמַ״ח for 248 and שַׁסַ״ה for 365. These numbers have mystical significance in Judaism, with 248 corresponding to the traditional count of positive commandments and the supposed number of limbs in the human body, while 365 corresponds to negative commandments and the days of the solar year.

[ii] This refers to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy revealed to Moses in Exodus 34:6-7, which form a central element in Jewish penitential prayers. The word ‘sod’ (mystery/secret) indicates that the text is referring to the kabbalistic understanding of these attributes.

[ii] [i]שַׁעֲרֵי תְּפִלָּה

Attributes[A] which You have entrusted to the gates of prayer.

שֶׁאֵינָם חוֹזְרוֹת רֵיקָם כַּאֲשֶׁר
הוֹדַעְתָּ לְעָנְיָו מִקֶּדֶם כְּמָה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר
וַיַּעֲבֹר יְיָ עַל פָּנָיו וַיִּקְרָא יְיָ יְיָ אֵל
רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב חֶסֶד
וֶאֱמֶת נוֹצֵר חֶסֶד לָאֲלָפִים נוֹשֵׂא
עָוֹן וָפֶשַׁע וְחַטָּאָה וְנַקֵּה:[iii] וּבְכֵן
יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ אֲהֶיֶה אֲשֶׁר
אֶהְיֶה[iv] שֶׁתּוֹפִיעַ נָא בַּחֲמוֹן רַחֲמֶיךָ
עָלַי וְעַל נַפְשִׁי וְרוּחִי וְנִשְׁמָתִי
וְעַל כָּל הַגִּלְוִים עִמִּי וְתַלְבִּין
כָּל אֲשֶׁר נִכְתָּם לְפָנֶיךָ מַעֲוֹנוֹתַי
בְּכֹחַ יְיָ אֲדֹנָי חֵילִי הַמַּלְבִּין עֲוֹנוֹת
וַחֲטָאוֹת תִּשְׁלַח נָא לִי אֶת הַחֶסֶד
וְאֶת הָרַחֲמִים וּבְכֹחַךָ זֶה תְּכַפֵּר
עַל כָּל חֲטָאַי שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם
כָּל מִינֵי מִיתָה בִּידֵי שָׁמַיִם:[v] עַל

which do not return empty, as You made known to the humble one of old, as it is said: "And the LORD passed before him and proclaimed: The LORD, the 2380R
LORD, God, merciful and gracious, long-suffering, and abundant in loving-kindness and truth; keeping mercy unto the thousandth generation, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, and pardoning." Therefore, may it be Your will, Ehyeh Asher 2385R
Ehyeh (I Am That I Am),[B] that You shine forth with Your abundant mercies upon me and upon my nefesh, my ruach, and my neshamah,[1] and upon all who accompany me. May You whiten all that has been stained before You by my iniquities through 2390R
the power of the LORD, my Master, my Strength, who whitens iniquities and sins. Please send forth to me loving-kindness and mercy, and through this

[A] Or: "through the mystical power of Your Thirteen Attributes" — The term 'sod' in kabbalistic contexts often refers not just to a 'mystery' but specifically to the esoteric or mystical dimension of interpretation. This translation better conveys the active spiritual power being invoked.

[B] Or: "And thus, may it be Your will, before You, "I Will Be What I Will Be"" — The divine name 'Ehyeh Asher Ehyeh' could be translated more literally as 'I Will Be What I Will Be' rather than using the traditional English rendering 'I Am That I Am.' This alternative preserves the future tense of the Hebrew verb and might better reflect the name's meaning in this context of divine promise and future redemption.

[1] These three Hebrew terms represent different aspects or levels of the soul in Jewish thought. Rather than simply translating them as 'soul,' I've retained the Hebrew terms to preserve the kabbalistic understanding of the soul's multiple components, which is important in the context of deathbed rituals.

[i] This phrase reflects the mystical concept that prayers ascend through specific 'gates' in heaven, with the Thirteen Attributes serving as keys that open these gates of prayer.

[ii] Cf. Yom Kippur Machzor, Al Chet confession — The confession in Ma'avar Yabok adapts the familiar Yom Kippur confession for use at the deathbed, preserving its rhythmic structure while adding mystical dimensions that connect physical sin to spiritual harm across multiple levels of the soul. | Cf. Exodus 34:6-7 — This reference establishes divine mercy as the basis for forgiveness, particularly appropriate in a deathbed context where the person lacks opportunity to demonstrate repentance through future actions. | Cf. Zohar on soul structure — By addressing sins committed through each soul level, this confession incorporates the Zoharic understanding that human actions affect different spiritual realms corresponding to each soul level.

[iii] This is a quotation of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy from Exodus 34:6-7, a central text in Jewish conceptions of divine forgiveness. According to rabbinic tradition, God taught Moses to recite these attributes as a formula for seeking divine forgiveness. In the context of deathbed confession, invoking these attributes creates a connection to this foundational moment of divine forgiveness.

[iv] This divine name, first revealed to Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3:14), is one of the most sacred names of God in Jewish tradition. In kabbalistic thought, it represents the highest level of divinity beyond human comprehension. Its use in this confession demonstrates the petition reaching to the highest level of divine mercy available.

[v] Jewish law distinguishes between sins punishable by 'death by the hands of Heaven' (divine punishment) and those punishable by human courts. This distinction forms the organizing principle for this confession, which systematically addresses different categories of sins based on their severity and prescribed punishment.

חַטָּאִים שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל מִינֵי
מִיתָה בִּידֵי אָדָם: עַל חֲטָאִים
שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל מִינֵי כָּרֵת:
עַל חֲטָאִים שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל
מִינֵי מִיתוֹת מְשֻׁנּוֹת: עַל חֲטָאִים
שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל מִינֵי קָרְבַּן
חַטָּאת וְאָשָׁם וְקָרְבָּן עוֹלָה וְיוֹרֵד:
עַל חֲטָאִים שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל
מִינֵי יִסּוּרִין: עַל חֲטָאִים שֶׁאֲנִי
חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל מִינֵי מַכַּת מַרְדּוּת:
עַל חֲטָאִים שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל
מִינֵי מַלְקוּת: עַל חֵטְא שֶׁחָטָאתִי
בְּבִטּוּל מִצְוַת עֲשֵׂה וּבְלָאו הַבָּא
מִכְּלַל עֲשֵׂה וּבְלָאו הַנִּתָּק לַעֲשֵׂה.
וְלָאו שֶׁאֵין בּוֹ מַעֲשֶׂה: עַל חֲטָאִים
שֶׁאֲנִי חַיָּב עֲלֵיהֶם כָּל אַרְבַּע
מִיתוֹת בֵּית דִּין: כָּל מִינֵי סְקִילָה
וְתוֹלְדוֹתֶיהָ וְכַדּוֹמֶה לָהּ: כָּל מִינֵי
שְׂרֵפָה וְתוֹלְדוֹתֶיהָ וְכַדּוֹמֶה לָהּ:
כָּל מִינֵי הֶרֶג וְתוֹלְדוֹתָיו וְכַדּוֹמֶה
לוֹ: כָּל מִינֵי חֶנֶק וְתוֹלְדוֹתָיו
וְכַדּוֹמֶה לוֹ: כִּי גָרַמְתִּי לְהַרְחִיק
הַמְקֻרָבִים וְאֲשֶׁר הֵם יַחְדּוּ תְּמִים
לְמַעְלָה רֹאשׁ[i] בְּעָבְרִי עַל מִצְוַת
עֲשֵׂה וְעַל מִצְוַת לֹא תַעֲשֶׂה וּבֵין
שֶׁגְּלוּיִים לִי בֵּין שֶׁאֵינָן גְּלוּיִים
לִי עַל כֻּלָּם אֱלוֹהַ הָרַחֲמִים בַּעַל
הַסְּלִיחוֹת סְלַח לִי מְחַל לִי כַּפֶּר
לִי: הַגְּלוּיִים לִי כְּבָר אֲמַרְתִּים
לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי. וְשֶׁאֵינָן גְּלוּיִים לִי
הַכֹּל גָּלוּי וְצָפוּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי
וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי כַּדָּבָר שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר
הַנִּסְתָּרוֹת לַיְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְהַנִּגְלוֹת

power of Yours, atone for all the sins for which I am liable to all forms of death by heavenly decree. For sins for which I am liable to all forms of death by human hands. For sins for which I am liable to all forms of excision.[A] For sins for which I am liable to all forms of unusual deaths. For sins for which I am liable to all types of sin offerings, guilt offerings, and variable offerings.[B] For sins for which I am liable to all types of suffering. For sins for which I am liable to all types of disciplinary lashes. For sins for which I am liable to all types of flogging. For the sin I committed by neglecting positive commandments, and negative commandments derived from positive ones, and negative commandments that can be remedied by a positive action, and negative commandments that involve no action. For sins for which I am liable to all four forms of capital punishment by the court: All forms of stoning and their derivatives and similar penalties. All forms of burning and their derivatives and similar penalties. All forms of beheading and their derivatives and similar penalties. All forms of strangulation and their derivatives and similar penalties. For I have caused those who should be brought near to become distant, and those who are perfectly united above to be separated,[C] by transgressing positive commandments and negative commandments, whether they are known to me or not known to me. For all of them, God of mercy, Master of forgiveness, forgive me, pardon me, atone for me. Those that are known to me I have already confessed before You, LORD my God. And those that are not known to me—all is revealed and known before You, LORD my God and God of my fathers, as it is written: "The

2395R 2400R 2405R 2410R 2415R 2420R 2425R

[A] Or: "For sins for which I am liable to all forms of spiritual cutting-off" — The term 'karet' (כָּרֵת) specifically refers to a divine punishment of being 'cut off' from one's people or from God. While 'excision' is technically accurate, 'spiritual cutting-off' might better convey the theological concept to readers unfamiliar with the technical term.

[B] Or: "and sliding-scale offerings" — The term 'korban oleh v'yored' refers specifically to offerings whose value could be adjusted based on the financial means of the person bringing them. 'Sliding-scale offerings' more precisely conveys this concept than the more general 'variable offerings.'

[C] Or: "For I have caused the divine attributes that should be brought near to become distant, and those that are perfectly united in the supernal realms" — In kabbalistic contexts like this confession, 'those who should be brought near' (הַמְקֻרָבִים) and 'those who are perfectly united above' (יַחְדּוּ תְּמִים לְמַעְלָה) often refer specifically to divine attributes or sefirot rather than people. This alternative translation makes the mystical dimension more explicit.

[i] This phrase reflects kabbalistic concepts about the cosmic impact of human sin. According to Lurianic Kabbalah, human transgressions cause separation between divine attributes (sefirot) that should be united. This confession thus acknowledges not just earthly transgressions but their cosmic impact on divine unity.

לָנוּ וּלְבָנֵינוּ עַד עוֹלָם[i] לַעֲשׂוֹת אֶת כָּל דִּבְרֵי הַתּוֹרָה הַזֹּאת: כִּי אַתָּה סָלְחָן לְיִשְׂרָאֵל וּמוֹחֲלָן לְשִׁבְטֵי יְשׁוּרוּן[ii] וּמִבַּלְעָדֶיךָ אֵין לָנוּ מֶלֶךְ מוֹחֵל וְסוֹלֵחַ. [iii]

secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the revealed things belong to us and to our children forever, to observe all the words of this Torah." For You are the Forgiver of Israel and the Pardoner of the tribes of Jeshurun,[1] and besides You, we have no king who pardons and forgives. 2430R

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי בִּזְכוּת אַבְרָהָם וְיִצְחָק וְיִשְׂרָאֵל עֲבָדֶיךָ שֶׁיִּהְיֶה נִרְצָה וְרָווּי זֶה לְפָנֶיךָ כְּאִלּוּ נִסְקַלְתִּי וְנִשְׂרַפְתִּי וְנֶהֱרַגְתִּי וְנֶחְנַקְתִּי כַּתּוֹרָה וְכַהֲלָכָה בְּבֵית דִּינָךְ הַגָּדוֹל שֶׁבִּירוּשָׁלַיִם עַל דְּבַר כְּבוֹד שְׁמֶךָ וְאִם פָּגַמְתִּי בְּהִרְהוּר אוֹ בְּמַחֲשָׁבָה אוֹ בְּדִבּוּר אוֹ בְּמַעֲשֶׂה בְּאוֹת רִאשׁוֹנָה אוֹ

May it be Your will, LORD my God and God of my fathers, by the merit of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel Your servants, that this confession of mine be accepted before You as if I had been stoned, burned, beheaded, and strangled[2] according to the Torah and law in Your great court in Jerusalem for the sake of the honor of Your Name. And if I have damaged through thought, contemplation, speech, or action the first, second, third, or fourth letter of Your great, mighty, and awesome Name,[A] or through other di- 2435R 2440R

[A] Or: "And if I have caused blemish through fleeting thoughts, deliberate contemplation, speech, or action to the first, second, third, or fourth letter of Your great, mighty, and awesome Name" — This alternative more precisely conveys the kabbalistic concept of 'pagam' (blemish/damage) to the divine letters and distinguishes between 'hirhur' (fleeting thought) and 'machshavah' (deliberate contemplation), which have distinct meanings in Jewish mystical tradition.

[1] Jeshurun is a poetic name for Israel found in biblical texts, particularly Deuteronomy. It derives from the Hebrew root meaning 'upright' and is generally understood as an affectionate or honorific term for the Jewish people.

[2] This vivid imagery connects personal suffering and natural death to the four formal death penalties of ancient Jewish courts. In Ma'avar Yabok, deathbed confession transforms ordinary death into sacred atonement through this metaphorical equivalence.

[i] This quotation from Deuteronomy 29:28 acknowledges the limitation of human awareness regarding sin. The confession recognizes that while a person may have consciously confessed known sins, there are unconscious or forgotten transgressions that only God knows. This humility is considered an essential aspect of complete repentance.

[ii] The term 'Jeshurun' is a poetic name for Israel found in Deuteronomy, Isaiah, and elsewhere in biblical literature. Its use here, alongside 'Israel,' creates a parallel structure emphasizing God's relationship with the Jewish people through multiple covenant names.

[iii] Cf. Exodus 34:6-7 — This biblical passage serves as the foundational text for the concept of divine forgiveness in Judaism. In the context of this confession, it reminds the dying person that God's mercy has been established as a covenant promise that can be invoked during times of judgment. | Cf. Deuteronomy 29:28 — The confession cites this verse to acknowledge that while the person has confessed known sins, there are likely unknown sins that only God can see. This humility is an important aspect of complete repentance, recognizing one's limited self-awareness while trusting in God's complete knowledge. | Cf. Yom Kippur liturgy — This deathbed confession adapts the Yom Kippur confession format, suggesting that the moment of death, like Yom Kippur, is understood as a time of judgment and atonement. The parallel implies that proper confession before death can achieve atonement similar to that of Yom Kippur. | Cf. Mishnah Sanhedrin — By referencing these specific punishments from rabbinic legal tradition, the confession acknowledges the seriousness of transgressions against Torah law. In the context of deathbed confession, this recognition of deserved punishment precedes the appeal to divine mercy, following the pattern of 'justice before mercy' in Jewish theological thought. | Cf. Zohar — This kabbalistic language reflects the Zoharic understanding that human sins cause separation in the upper divine worlds. Specifically, transgressions disrupt the proper unification of divine attributes (sefirot), particularly between the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity. This confession thus acknowledges cosmic damage caused by sin, not merely personal wrongdoing.

שְׁנִיָּה אוֹ שְׁלִישִׁית אוֹ רְבִיעִית
מִשְׁמָךְ הַגָּדוֹל הַגִּבּוֹר וְהַנּוֹרָא[i] אוֹ
2280 בַּהֲוָיוֹת אֲחֵרוֹת אוֹ בְּאוֹתִיּוֹת
אֲחֵרוֹת הַתְּלוּיוֹת בָּהֶם וְנִתְחַיַּבְתִּי
לִפְנֵי כִסֵּא כְבוֹדֶךָ אַרְבַּע מִיתוֹת
אֵלּוּ.[ii] תַּעֲמֹד לְפָנֶיךָ צִדְקַת
אַבְרָהָם אוֹהֲבֶךָ וְיִצְחָק עֲקֵדְךָ
2285 וְיִשְׂרָאֵל יְדִידֶךָ וּשְׁנֵים עָשָׂר שִׁבְטֵי
יָהּ עֲבָדֶיךָ. וְיִהְיֶה חָשׁוּב וּמְקֻבָּל
לְפָנֶיךָ צַעֲרִי וִיסוּרַי גּוּפִי עִם
קָרְבָּן נִשְׁמָתִי בִּיצִיאָתָהּ מִמֶּנִּי
בְּאֹרֶךְ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים כְּאִלּוּ
2290 נִתְקַיְּמוּ בִּי אַרְבַּע מִיתוֹת בֵּית דִּין
בְּבֵית דִּינְךָ הַגָּדוֹל שֶׁבִּירוּשָׁלַיִם
בִּמַעֲמַד כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל וְיָצְאָה נַפְשִׁי
בְּקְדֻשָּׁה וּבְטָהֳרָה עַל קְדֻשַּׁת שִׁמְךָ
הַגָּדוֹל הַמְּחֻיֶּה אֶת הַכֹּל וּלְפִיּוּס
2295 כָּל אֶחָד מֵאַרְבַּע אוֹתִיּוֹתָיו: וְאַתָּה
בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים תָּשׁוּב וּתְיַחֵד עָלַי
כָּל אֶחָד מֵאַרְבָּעָה אוֹתִיּוֹת[iii]
כָּל אֶחָד מִשְּׁלֹשָׁה שְׁמוֹתֶיךָ הַיְקָרִים
הֲוָיָה אֲהָיֶה אַדְנוּת.[iv] וְיָאִירוּ

vine Names or the letters dependent upon them, and have thereby become liable before Your throne of glory to these four death penalties—may the righ- 2445R
teousness of Abraham Your beloved, Isaac who was bound for You, Israel Your beloved, and the twelve tribes of God Your servants stand before You. And may my pain and bodily suffering, together with the sacrifice of my soul as it departs from me[A] after a 2450R
long life and years of living, be considered and accepted before You as if the four court-imposed death penalties had been carried out upon me in Your great court in Jerusalem in the presence of all Israel, and may my soul depart in holiness and purity for the 2455R
sanctification of Your great Name that gives life to all, and as appeasement for each of the four letters of Your Name. And You, in Your abundant mercy, return and unify upon me each of the four letters of each of Your three precious Names: YHVH, Ehyeh, 2460R
and Adonut.[B] May they all shine together in the worlds of Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah,[1] as befits the King without hindrance. Together may they be complete—the attribute of night within day

[A] Or: "And may my pain and bodily sufferings, together with the offering of my soul at its departure from me" — This alternative renders 'korban nishmati' as 'offering of my soul' rather than 'sacrifice of my soul,' which may better reflect the concept that the soul itself is being presented as a sacred offering rather than being destroyed, and treats the departure of the soul as a sacred ritual act similar to Temple offerings.

[B] Or: "And You, in Your abundant mercy, restore and effect the unification upon me of each of the four letters of each of Your three precious Names: YHVH, Ehyeh, and Adonut" — This alternative better conveys the kabbalistic concept of 'yichud' (unification) as an active cosmic process rather than a simple joining, and treats 'tashuv' as 'restore' rather than literally 'return,' which better captures the theological concept of divine restoration of cosmic harmony.

[1] These four worlds represent decreasing levels of spirituality in kabbalistic cosmology: Atzilut (Emanation) is pure divinity, Beriah (Creation) is where souls originate, Yetzirah (Formation) is where angels dwell, and Asiyah (Action) includes the physical world we inhabit.

[i] This three-part epithet ('great, mighty, and awesome') for God's name comes from the biblical verse Deuteronomy 10:17 and appears in the standard Amidah prayer. In kabbalistic thought, causing 'damage' to divine names through sin creates cosmic disruption that confession aims to repair.

[ii] The 'four death penalties' refer to the four methods of capital punishment administered by the ancient Jewish high court (Sanhedrin): stoning, burning, beheading, and strangling. In kabbalistic tradition, different sins damage different letters of God's name, making one liable to these punishments. This confession transforms natural death into spiritual atonement by comparing it to these judicial punishments.

[iii] The concept of 'unifying' (yichud) divine letters and names is central to kabbalistic practice. Sin is understood to cause separation or damage to divine names, while proper intention, prayer, and confession restore their unity and proper flow through all spiritual worlds.

[iv] These are three divine names: YHVH (the Tetragrammaton), Ehyeh ("I will be," from Exodus 3:14), and Adonut (from the name Adonai, "my Lord"). In kabbalah, each name represents different aspects of divine manifestation and governance. Each is treated as having four letters, with specific cosmic significance.

בֻּלָּם יַחַד בְּעוֹלָמוֹת אֲצִילוּת
בְּרִיאָה יְצִירָה עֲשִׂיָּה.[i] כְּיַד
הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּלִי מוֹנֵעַ. וְיַחְדָּו יִהְיוּ
תַּמִּים מַדַּת לַיְלָה בְּיוֹם וּמַדַּת
יוֹם בַּלַּיְלָה וְחִבַּרְתָּ אֶת הָאֹהֶל
וְהָיָה אֶחָד.[ii] וְיֵצֵא נָא חֵפֶץ מַכְּתֶר
הָרַחֲמִים דַּרְכְּךָ נְתִיבוֹת הַמַּחֲשָׁבָה
וַחֲבִינֵנִי גְּדֻלָּתֶךָ וּגְבוּרָתֶךָ
וְאֶתְפָּאֵר בְּנָצַח הוֹדְךָ וְאֶתְיַסֵּד
בְּמַלְכוּתֶךָ.[iii] וְאִם אֶצְטָרֵךְ מַיִם
לַעֲלוֹת מִטְּמְאָה לְטַהֲרָה יֵצְאוּ
מַיִם הַחַיִּים מֵרְחוֹבוֹת הַנָּהָר לְקַו
הָאֶמְצָעִי מְיָכִין לְבַעַז[iv] נָהָר
פְּלָגָיו וּמַעְיָן מִבֵּית יְיָ יֵצֵא וּבוֹ
אֶטְבֹּל וְאֶטְהָר וְאָמוּל עָרְלַת
לִבָּבִי[v] וְלֹא אָשׁוּב עוֹד לְהָעִיז
פָּנָי. וְאַתָּה בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים תִּהְיֶה
בְּעֶזְרָתִי וְתִתֵּן בִּי כֹּחַ לַעֲשׂוֹת
חַיִל וְתַעֲבִיר מֻמְנֵי טֻמְאַת יִצְרִי
הָרָע:[vi]

and the attribute of day within night[1]—and "You shall join the tent together so it becomes one." May desire flow forth from the Crown of Mercy through the pathways of thought, and grant me understanding of Your greatness and might, that I may glory in the eternal splendor of Your majesty and be established in Your kingdom. And if I need water to ascend from impurity to purity, may living waters flow from the expanses of the river to the middle line, from Jachin to Boaz,[2] "a river whose streams make glad," and "a fountain shall go forth from the house of the LORD," and in it I will immerse and be purified, and circumcise the foreskin of my heart,[3] and no longer act defiantly. And You, in Your abundant mercy, be my help and give me strength to act valiantly, and remove from me the impurity of my evil inclination.[4]

[1]This reflects the kabbalistic principle of cosmic balance between opposing forces. 'Night' typically represents divine judgment/severity while 'day' represents mercy/kindness. Their integration creates cosmic harmony.

[2]These were the names of the two pillars flanking the entrance to Solomon's Temple. In kabbalistic symbolism, they represent the right and left columns of the sefirotic tree—the pillars of mercy and judgment that must be balanced through the central column.

[3]This biblical metaphor from Deuteronomy represents the removal of spiritual obstinacy and resistance to divine will. In this deathbed context, it expresses the desire for complete spiritual surrender and purification before death.

[4]The 'evil inclination' (yetzer ha-ra) in Jewish thought is not inherently evil but represents self-centered desires that can lead to sin when not properly channeled. This confession seeks purification from its negative aspects before death.

[i]These are the four spiritual worlds in kabbalistic cosmology: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action), arranged in descending order from the most spiritual to the most material. The prayer seeks divine illumination through all levels of reality.

[ii]This is a direct quote from Exodus 26:11 regarding the construction of the Tabernacle. In this context, it becomes a metaphor for cosmic unification—the joining of 'night' and 'day' attributes (likely referring to judgment and mercy) into perfect divine harmony.

[iii]This passage uses terminology from the lower sefirot (divine attributes): Netzach (Eternity/Victory), Hod (Splendor), and Malkhut (Kingdom). The supplicant seeks integration with these divine qualities through proper confession.

[iv]Jachin and Boaz were the names of the two pillars at the entrance to Solomon's Temple (1 Kings 7:21). In kabbalistic symbolism, they represent the masculine and feminine cosmic principles, or the pillars of mercy and judgment on the Tree of Life diagram.

[v]This metaphor of 'circumcising the heart' comes from Deuteronomy 10:16, where it represents removing spiritual obstinacy. In this confession, it expresses the desire for complete spiritual purification and surrender to divine will at the moment of death.

[vi]Cf. Zohar — This confession draws on Zoharic concepts about how human sin damages divine Names and how proper confession can repair these damages, allowing the divine letters to be reunified and shine properly through all four spiritual worlds. | Cf. Four death penalties of the Sanhedrin — The confession employs these four death penalties metaphorically, suggesting that the confessor's suffering and approaching death should be accepted as atonement equivalent to these judicial punishments, transforming natural death into a sacred act of atonement. | Cf. Exodus

אָנָּא בַּעַל הַחֶסֶד בְּאֹרֶךְ אַפַּיִם
תְּדִינֵנִי.[i] וְאַל תַּעֲלֵנִי נָא מִן
הָעוֹלָם הַזֶּה בַּחֲטִיפָה עַד שֶׁאֶבְרֹר
מָנָה יָפָה וּמָדוֹר לְנִשְׁמָתִי[ii] הַטְהוֹרָה
בְּמַשְׂכִּיּוֹת הָאוֹרָה וּמִשְּׁמַן
אַפְרְסְמוֹן וּמִטַּל חֶרְמוֹן[iii] תַּרְבֶּה
חֶלְקִי וּלְחַיֵּי הָעוֹלָם הַבָּא תֵּן
לִי חֵלֶק בְּלִי קִצְבָה נַחֲלָה
בְּלֹא מְצָרִים.[iv] וּתְצַוֵּה נָא
לְמַלְאָכֶיךָ הַקְּדוֹשִׁים הַמְמֻנִּים
עַל הַתּוֹרָה[v] שֶׁיָּאִירוּ עֵינַי
בְּמִקְרָא בְּמִשְׁנָה בְּתַלְמוּד
בַּהֲלָכוֹת בַּאֲגָדוֹת וְסִתְרֵי תוֹרָה
וְחֻקֶּיהָ וּמִשְׁפָּטֶיהָ. וּפְתַח לִבִּי
וּכְלָיוֹתַי[vi] לְהָבִין וּלְהַאֲזִין
פִּקּוּדֶיךָ וְלִשְׁמֹר מִצְוֹתֶיךָ וּתְזַכֵּנִי
לִלְמֹד וּלְלַמֵּד לְהָבִין וּלְהוֹרוֹת

O Master of Kindness, judge me with patience and forbearance. Please do not take me from this world hastily, until I have chosen a fine portion and dwelling for my pure soul in the chambers of light.[A] From balsam oil and the dew of Hermon, increase my portion, and for life in the World to Come, grant me an unlimited share, an inheritance without boundaries. Please command Your holy angels who are appointed over the Torah[B] to enlighten my eyes in Scripture, Mishnah, Talmud, halakhot, aggadot, the secrets of Torah, its statutes, and its judgments. Open my heart and my innermost being[1] to understand and heed Your precepts and to observe Your commandments. Grant me merit to learn and to teach, to understand and to instruct, to observe and to practice, from now until eternity. Increase my territory with students in this world

[A] Or: "a beautiful portion and abode for the pure soul in the luminous chambers" — This alternate translation is more poetic and captures the aesthetic quality implied by 'yafah' (beautiful rather than merely 'fine'). 'Abode' might better convey the sense of permanent residence implied by 'mador' than 'dwelling', and 'luminous chambers' has a more mystical resonance that fits the context.

[B] Or: "Please instruct Your holy angels who are custodians of the Torah" — The term 'memunnim' implies guardianship and oversight rather than merely being 'appointed'. 'Custodians' better captures the active role these angels play in preserving and transmitting Torah knowledge in kabbalistic thought.

[1] The Hebrew uses 'heart and kidneys' (libi v'kilyotai), reflecting the biblical conception of kidneys as the seat of deep emotions and inner thoughts.

26:11 — The biblical verse about joining the Tabernacle is repurposed here as a mystical metaphor for the unification of divine attributes and cosmic harmony that the confessor hopes to achieve through proper deathbed confession. | Cf. Joel 4:18 — This prophetic verse is reinterpreted in the confession as a personal prayer for spiritual purification, where the eschatological fountain becomes a metaphorical mikveh (ritual bath) for the soul's cleansing before its final journey. | Cf. Deuteronomy 10:16 — The metaphor of heart circumcision represents the removal of spiritual barriers and obstinacy, expressing the confessor's desire for complete spiritual transformation and openness to divine influence at the moment of death. | Cf. Kabbalistic doctrine of the Four Worlds — The confession seeks to repair damage caused by sin across all four spiritual worlds, reflecting the kabbalistic understanding that human actions affect the entire cosmic structure from the highest divine realms to the physical world.

[i] The prayer begins by addressing God as 'Master of Kindness' and requesting judgment with patience. The phrase 'orekh apayim' (literally 'long of nostrils/face') is a traditional attribute of divine mercy, referring to God's patience before expressing anger.

[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that one's actions in this world determine the 'portion' (manah) and 'dwelling' (mador) that their soul will inhabit in the afterlife.

[iii] These are metaphors for divine abundance. Balsam oil was highly valued in ancient times, and the dew of Mount Hermon is referenced in Psalm 133 as a symbol of blessing.

[iv] A reference to the Talmudic concept of 'nachalah bli metzarim' (inheritance without boundaries), describing the unlimited spiritual reward in the World to Come.

[v] In Jewish mystical thought, different angels are appointed over various aspects of Torah study and spiritual wisdom.

[vi] In biblical Hebrew, the kidneys (kelayot) were considered the seat of emotion and inner thoughts, similar to how we refer to the heart today.

לִשְׁמֹר וְלַעֲשׂוֹת[i] מֵעַתָּה וְעַד
עוֹלָם וְתַרְבֶּה גְּבוּלִי בְּתַלְמִידִים
בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא וּזְכוּת
הָרַבִּים יִתְגַּלְגֵּל עַל יָדִי לְעוֹלָם
וָעֶד וְכֵן מַחֲשַׁבְתִּי לַעֲבֹד לְפָנֶיךָ
בֶּאֱמֶת וּבְאַהֲבָה וּבְיִרְאָה וּבְרָעָדָה
וּבְאֵימָה וְעֵינַי יָאִירוּ וְעַפְעַפַּי
יְיַשְּׁרוּ. וְנִשְׁמָתִי תְּיַחֵדְךָ וְנַפְשִׁי
תְּפָאֵר אוֹתְךָ אַף רוּחִי בְּקֶרְבִּי
יְשַׁחֵר לִשְׁמֶךָ[ii] וְאֵלֶךְ בְּאוֹר
הַנְּשָׁמָה הַטְּהוֹרָה אֶל מוּל פְּנֵי
הַמְּנוֹרָה[iii] וּבְגִדֵי יֶשַׁע תַּלְבִּישֵׁנִי
וּבְצָעִיף צְדָקָה תְּעַטְּרֵנִי[iv] וְרָצוּי
תְּקַבְּלֵנִי וְאֶנְחַל שְׁנֵי עוֹלָמִים יַחְדָּו
יְהִיוּ תָמִים.[v] וְטָרֵם תִּלָּקַח נַפְשִׁי
מִגּוּפִי יְהֵא תַלְמוּדִי סָדוּר וְשָׁגוּר
בְּפִי[vi] וְלֹא אֵבוֹשׁ בְּשַׁעֲרֵי פְּלַטְרֵיךָ
וְזַכֵּנִי לְנַעֵם רָזֵי הַתּוֹרָה הַקְּדוּמָה
וְיִתְיַחֵד שִׁמְךָ בִּי[vii] לִהְיוֹת מַעֲטֶה
תְּהִלָּה וְנָוֶר תִּפְאָרָה וְאֶזְכֶּה

and in the World to Come, and may the merit of the many be attributed to me forever. Direct my thoughts to serve before You in truth, with love, with awe, with trembling, and with reverence. May my eyes shine and my eyelids be straightened.[1] May my soul unify You, my nefesh glorify You, and my spirit within me seek Your name at dawn.[2] May I walk in the light of the pure soul toward the face of the menorah.[A] Clothe me in garments of salvation and crown me with the veil of righteousness. Accept me favorably, and may I inherit both worlds together in perfection.[3] Before my soul is taken from my body, may my learning be ordered and fluent in my mouth,[B] that I not be ashamed in the gates of Your palace. Grant me merit to experience the pleasantness of the mysteries of the primordial Torah, and may Your name be unified through me to be a mantle of praise and a crown of glory. May I merit to stroll in the delight of Your courts and to see the goodness of Your chosen ones, to stand and

[A] Or: "May I proceed by the illumination of the pure soul toward the presence of the divine candelabrum" — This alternative better conveys the mystical significance of the menorah as more than just a physical object but a divine symbol of enlightenment. 'Proceed' captures the spiritual journey implied, and 'illumination' connects more directly with the light metaphor prevalent throughout the prayer.

[B] Or: "Before my soul departs from my body, may my Torah learning be systematically arranged and flowing readily from my lips" — This translation better captures the technical terms 'sadur' and 'shagur' which specifically refer to having one's learning organized in memory and readily accessible for recitation. The prayer expresses the wish to have full command of one's Torah knowledge at the moment of death, when one must 'give an account' in the heavenly court.

[1] This poetic expression comes from Proverbs 4:25, referring to moral clarity and spiritual focus. The straightened eyelids represent looking directly toward divine truth without distraction.

[2] This passage reflects the kabbalistic concept of the three-part soul: neshamah (highest spiritual level), nefesh (vital soul), and ruach (spirit/middle level). Each connects with divinity in a different way: unification, glorification, and seeking.

[3] This refers to the rabbinic concept that the righteous merit reward in both this world and the World to Come, with the two harmoniously integrated rather than in conflict.

[i] This formulaic sequence appears in traditional Jewish liturgy, particularly in blessings over Torah study, emphasizing the progression from learning to teaching to practicing.

[ii] This passage refers to the three levels of the soul in Kabbalah: neshamah (highest), ruach (middle), and nefesh (vital soul), each engaging with divinity in a different way.

[iii] The menorah symbolizes divine light and wisdom. This passage expresses the hope that the soul's inherent purity will guide one toward spiritual illumination.

[iv] Based on Isaiah 61:10, this imagery of being clothed in salvation and wrapped in righteousness represents spiritual protection and divine favor.

[v] This refers to the Jewish concept that the righteous inherit both this world and the World to Come, enjoying them in perfect harmony.

[vi] Traditional Jewish teaching emphasized that one's learning should be 'arranged and fluent in one's mouth' so that when appearing before the heavenly court, one can properly account for their Torah knowledge.

[vii] In Kabbalistic thought, the unification of God's name refers to the mystical process of restoring cosmic harmony through proper spiritual intention and action.

לְטַיֵּל בְּתַעֲנוּג חֲצֵרֶיךָ וְלִרְאוֹת
בְּטוּבַת בְּחִירֶיךָ לַעֲמֹד לְשָׁרֵת כָּל
הַיָּמִים לְפָנֶיךָ וְרִוּחַ נָבוֹן חַדֵּשׁ
בְּקִרְבִּי וְעֵינַי תִּרְאֶינָה יְרוּשָׁלַיִם
וְצִיּוֹן וַהֲדוֹד וְהַנֶּצַח[i] וּנְוֵה
אַפִּרְיוֹן וְנִגּוּהַ אֵשׁ לֶהָבָה הַדָּבֵק
בְּחֶשֶׁק הָאַהֲבָה[ii] וְחַיֵּי הָעוֹלָם
הַבָּא וְהַעֲלֵנִי בְּחִבָּה אֶל מָעוֹן
הַטּוֹב שֶׁאֵין לוֹ קְצָבָה וְאַפְקֵד
בְּאַהֲבָה רַבָּה וְתִהְיֶה שָׁמָּה בִּצְרוֹר
הַחַיִּים צְרוּרָה נְשָׁמָה שֶׁנָּתַתָּ בִּי
טְהוֹרָה:[iii] [iv]

serve before You all my days. Renew a proper spirit within me, and may my eyes behold Jerusalem and 2520R
Zion, the splendor and the victory,[1] the pavilion of royalty, and the brightness of the flame that cleaves with passionate love and the life of the World to Come. Raise me with affection to the good dwelling that has no limit, and may I depart with abundant 2525R
love.[2] May the pure soul You placed within me be bound in the bond of life.[A]

אָנָּא נוֹרָא קָדוֹשׁ תַּרְבֶּה Please, O Awesome and Holy One, increase Your

[A] Or: "And there, may the pure soul You placed within me be gathered into the treasury of eternal life" — The Hebrew 'tzeror ha-chayyim' (literally 'bundle of life') has traditionally been translated as 'bond of life,' but the metaphor actually suggests a treasury or repository where precious items are kept safe. This alternate translation preserves both the imagery of being 'gathered in' (tzrurah) and the concept of safekeeping implied in the original Hebrew metaphor.

[1] The Hebrew terms 'hod' and 'netzach' refer both to Jerusalem's glory and to specific divine attributes (sefirot) in Kabbalah, connecting the physical Jerusalem with its spiritual counterpart.
[2] The prayer acknowledges death ('depart') but frames it positively as a loving transition rather than a fearful event, consistent with Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a spiritual crossing.

[i] This combines messianic hope for the restoration of Jerusalem with kabbalistic references to the divine attributes of Hod (splendor) and Netzach (victory/eternity).
[ii] This poetic phrasing describes mystical divine love using the metaphor of clinging flame, a common image in Jewish mystical literature.
[iii] The phrase 'bound in the bond of life' (tzeror ha-chayyim) comes from I Samuel 25:29 and became a traditional expression in Jewish mourning, appearing on gravestones and in memorial prayers. Here it expresses hope for the soul's eternal connection to divine life.
[iv] Cf. Psalm 133:3 — The prayer uses this biblical image of the dew of Hermon to represent divine abundance and blessing that the supplicant hopes will increase their spiritual portion. In Psalm 133, this dew is described as descending on Zion as a symbol of harmony and divine favor. | Cf. Isaiah 61:10 — The prayer's phrases 'clothe me in garments of salvation' and 'crown me with the veil of righteousness' directly echo Isaiah's imagery, expressing hope for divine protection and favor. These garments symbolize spiritual transformation and divine acceptance. | Cf. I Samuel 25:29 — The concluding phrase of the prayer, 'bound in the bond of life,' comes directly from this biblical source. What began as a blessing for the living in Samuel became a traditional expression in Jewish mourning liturgy for the soul's eternal connection to God after death. Its use in this prayer shows how Ma'avar Yabok integrates biblical language into its deathbed liturgy. | Cf. Midrash Tanchuma, Pekudei 3 — The prayer's reference to 'angels appointed over the Torah' reflects rabbinic and mystical traditions that specific angels oversee different domains of knowledge. In kabbalistic thought, these angels assist humans in accessing divine wisdom, which explains why the supplicant asks God to command these angels to enlighten their understanding. | Cf. Zohar III:245a — The prayer's tripartite structure of 'my neshamah will unify You, my nefesh glorify You, and my ruach seek Your name' parallels Zoharic teachings about how each soul level connects with divinity in its unique way. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's deep engagement with kabbalistic concepts, particularly regarding the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 17a — This prayer echoes traditional rabbinic prayers for Torah study, particularly in its request for understanding Scripture, Mishnah, Talmud, and other aspects of Jewish learning. The structure and language suggest it follows established patterns of rabbinic supplication, adapted for the context of preparing for death.

מְחִילָתֶךָ:[i] פְּשַׁעֵינוּ סְלָחָה:
תְּגַלְגֵּל מִדּוֹתֶיךָ:[ii] פְּתַח סְלִיחָה
פְּתַח סָעַד יֶשַׁע מָנָתֶךָ: דְּרֹשׁ
יוֹדְעֵי וְעוּדֶיךָ[iii] נָא סְמֹךְ יַחַד
מַחֲנוֹתֶיךָ:[iv] יָחִיד הַשְׁקִיפָה וְהַבֵּט
שְׁכִינָתֶךָ:[v] יִשְׂמְחוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וְתָגֵל
הָאָרֶץ בְּהִגָּלוֹת מַלְכוּתֶךָ: וְכָל
הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל יָהּ הַלְלוּיָהּ: וַאֲנִי
תְפִלָּתִי לְךָ יְיָ עֵת רָצוֹן אֱלֹהִים
בְּרֹב חַסְדֶּךָ עֲנֵנִי בֶּאֱמֶת יִשְׁעֶךָ: מִי
אֵל כָּמוֹךָ נוֹשֵׂא עָוֹן וְעוֹבֵר עַל
פֶּשַׁע לִשְׁאֵרִית נַחֲלָתוֹ לֹא הֶחֱזִיק
לָעַד אַפּוֹ כִּי חָפֵץ חֶסֶד הוּא: יָשׁוּב
יְרַחֲמֵנוּ יִכְבֹּשׁ עֲוֹנוֹתֵינוּ וְתַשְׁלִיךְ
בִּמְצוּלוֹת יָם כָּל חַטֹּאתָם: תִּתֵּן
אֱמֶת לְיַעֲקֹב חֶסֶד לְאַבְרָהָם אֲשֶׁר

forgiveness.[1] Pardon our transgressions. Roll forth Your attributes of mercy.[A] Open the gates of forgiveness, open and support the salvation that is our portion.[B] Seek out those who know Your appointed times,[C] please support together Your encampments.[2] O Unique One, look down and behold Your Divine Presence. Let the heavens rejoice and the earth exult when Your kingship is revealed.[3] And let every soul praise the LORD, Hallelujah. But as for me, my prayer is to You, O LORD, at a favorable time; O God, in the abundance of Your loving kindness, answer me with the truth of Your salvation. Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and overlooks transgression[4] for the remnant of His heritage? He does not maintain His anger forever, for He delights in kindness. He

2530R 2535R 2540R

[A] Or: "Set Your attributes in motion" — The Hebrew verb 'תְּגַלְגֵּל' conveys the image of rolling or turning like a wheel. While 'roll forth' captures the literal meaning, 'set in motion' might better convey the functional meaning of activating or implementing God's merciful attributes.

[B] Or: "open and strengthen the deliverance that is our share" — The Hebrew 'סְעַד' has connotations of supporting, strengthening, or sustaining, while 'יֶשַׁע' can be translated as 'salvation' or 'deliverance.' Similarly, 'מָנָתְךָ' can be understood as 'our portion' or 'our share.' This alternate translation offers slightly different nuances that might better capture the intended meaning in certain contexts.

[C] Or: "Attend to those who understand Your divine meetings" — The term 'וְעוּדֶיךָ' has connotations beyond just 'appointed times' and can refer to meetings, assemblies, or encounters with the divine. This alternate translation emphasizes the relational aspect rather than just the temporal one.

[1] The opening lines follow a poetic structure with many phrases beginning with different Hebrew letters, creating a semi-acrostic pattern that is difficult to preserve in translation.

[2] The reference to God's 'encampments' (מַחֲנוֹתֶיךָ) may have dual significance: referring to both the earthly Jewish communities and heavenly angelic hosts, with the prayer asking for unity between these realms.

[3] This line connects to messianic concepts in Jewish tradition, where the full revelation of divine kingship is associated with the ultimate redemption and cosmic joy.

[4] The original Hebrew uses the phrases 'נוֹשֵׂא עָוֹן' (literally 'bearing iniquity') and 'עוֹבֵר עַל פֶּשַׁע' (literally 'passing over transgression'), which are technical terms from the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy in Exodus 34:6-7.

[i] The Hebrew term 'מְחִילָתֶךָ' (Your forgiveness) is related to the word 'מְחִילָה' (mechilah), which in Jewish tradition refers to the complete wiping away of sin rather than merely pardoning it.

[ii] The phrase 'roll forth Your attributes' uses the verb 'תְּגַלְגֵּל' (from the root meaning 'to roll') with 'מִדּוֹתֶיךָ' (Your attributes), referring to God's Thirteen Attributes of Mercy. The imagery suggests setting these attributes in motion like a wheel to activate divine compassion.

[iii] The term 'וְעוּדֶיךָ' (Your appointed times) may refer to those who know the proper times for prayer according to Jewish tradition, or alternatively, those who understand God's appointed festivals or cosmic cycles.

[iv] The phrase 'support together Your encampments' likely refers to the kabbalistic concept of divine encampments or hosts, potentially connecting to the biblical concept of 'Mahanaim' (two camps) mentioned elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as significant at the time of death.

[v] The request for God to 'look down and behold Your Divine Presence' reflects the kabbalistic concept that the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) can become separated or distanced from the higher aspects of divinity, requiring divine attention and reunification.

נִשְׁבַּעְתָּ לַאֲבוֹתֵינוּ מִימֵי קֶדֶם׃ [i]

will again have compassion on us, He will subdue our iniquities, and You will cast all their sins into the depths of the sea. You will give truth to Jacob, kindness to Abraham, as You have sworn to our forefathers from ancient times.[1] 2545R

ויכוין לי״ג מדות של ארך אנפין[ii] כנדרש בספר פרדס׃ [iv iii]

He should direct his intention to the Thirteen Attributes of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One)[A] as expounded in the book of Pardes.[B] 2550R

2390 יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי שֶׁלֹּא אֶחֱטָא עוֹד

May it be Your will, LORD my God and God of my fathers, that I shall sin no more, and that

[A] Or: "He should focus his mystical meditation on the Thirteen Attributes of the Divine Countenance" — This alternative translation avoids the technical kabbalistic term 'Arich Anpin' in favor of a more accessible English phrase, which might be preferable for readers without background in Kabbalah. However, it loses the specificity of the kabbalistic concept being referenced.

[B] Or: "following the method detailed in Pardes Rimmonim" — This alternative explicitly names the full title of the book being referenced (Pardes Rimmonim by Moses Cordovero) rather than using the abbreviated form. This provides more clarity but is slightly less faithful to the exact wording of the original text.

[1] The prayer concludes with a reference to God's ancient covenant promises to the patriarchs, connecting the immediate request for forgiveness with the long historical relationship between God and Israel.

[i] Cf. Micah 7:18-20 — These verses from Micah are frequently used in Jewish liturgy related to forgiveness and divine mercy, particularly during the Ten Days of Repentance between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur. Their inclusion here connects this prayer to established penitential traditions. | Cf. Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7) — The phrase 'תְּגַלְגֵּל מִדּוֹתֶיךָ' (Roll forth Your attributes) alludes to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy revealed to Moses after the sin of the Golden Calf, which became a central formula in Jewish penitential prayers. | Cf. Psalm 69:14 — The direct quote from Psalm 69:14 'וַאֲנִי תְפִלָּתִי לְךָ יְיָ עֵת רָצוֹן' is frequently used in Jewish liturgy to introduce personal supplications, expressing hope that the prayer is being offered at a time of divine receptivity. | Cf. Psalm 150:6 — The quote 'כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל יָהּ הַלְלוּיָהּ' comes from the final verse of Psalm 150, which concludes the entire Book of Psalms. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this reference to all souls praising God creates a connection between individual supplication and universal praise. | Cf. 1 Chronicles 16:31 — The line 'יִשְׂמְחוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וְתָגֵל הָאָרֶץ' echoes 1 Chronicles 16:31 from David's song of thanksgiving when the Ark was brought to Jerusalem. In this context, it expresses hope for divine revelation and redemption.

[ii] This refers to the Thirteen Attributes of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One), a kabbalistic concept referring to a divine configuration within the highest levels of the sefirotic system. Unlike the better-known Thirteen Attributes of Mercy mentioned in Exodus 34:6-7, these attributes are specifically associated with Arich Anpin, which represents a higher and more concealed aspect of divinity in Lurianic Kabbalah.

[iii] This refers to "Pardes Rimmonim" (Orchard of Pomegranates), an influential kabbalistic work by Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), which systematically presents kabbalistic teachings. The instruction indicates that the practitioner should focus their intention according to the specific method outlined in this text.

[iv] Cf. Pardes Rimmonim by Moses Cordovero — This reference to Pardes Rimmonim indicates that the dying person should concentrate on a specific kabbalistic meditation detailed in Cordovero's work. This advanced mystical practice was believed to facilitate the soul's ascent through higher divine realms and connection to the highest sources of divine mercy as the person approached death. | Cf. Zohar — The concept of Arich Anpin and its thirteen attributes originates in the Zohar's Idra Rabba section, which explores the structure of divine emanation in great detail. By referring to these attributes, Ma'avar Yabok is connecting deathbed practices to the highest and most esoteric aspects of kabbalistic cosmology.

וַאֲשֶׁר חָטָאתִי מָרוֹק בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים[i] אֲבָל לֹא עַל יְדֵי יְסוּרִים וָחֳלָיִים רָעִים[ii] וְתַשְׁלִיכֵם בִּמְצוּלוֹת יָם[iii] בִּמְקוֹם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִזָּכְרוּ וְלֹא יִפָּקְדוּ וְלֹא יַעֲלוּ עַל לֵב[iv] מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם כָּל חַטֹּאתַי וְכָל חַטֹּאת עַמְּךָ בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל: וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר עָוֹן וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי ג״פ:[v] עוֹשֶׂה שָׁלוֹם בִּמְרוֹמָיו הוּא בְּרַחֲמָיו יַעֲשֶׂה שָׁלוֹם עָלֵינוּ וְעַל כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל אָמֵן:[vi]

which I have sinned, cleanse through Your abundant mercy,[A] but not through suffering and evil illnesses. Cast my sins into the depths of the sea,[B] to a place where they will not be remembered, nor be accounted for, nor rise up in anyone's heart[C] from now until eternity[1]—all my sins and all the sins of Your people, the house of Israel. "And He, being merciful, atones for iniquity and does not destroy; He frequently turns away His anger and does not arouse all His wrath." May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart find favor before You,[2] LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer [recite three times].[D] May He who makes peace in His heights,[3] in His abundant mercy, make peace upon

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[A] Or: "purify through Your great compassion" — The Hebrew מָרוֹק (m'rok) carries connotations of polishing or scouring clean, which might be better conveyed by 'purify' in some contexts. 'Compassion' is also a valid alternative to 'mercy' for רַחֲמֶיךָ.

[B] Or: "Cast them into the ocean depths" — While the original translation is more explicit by adding 'my sins' (which is implied but not explicit in the Hebrew), this alternate preserves the more poetic, concise style of the original with the pronoun 'them' referring back to sins.

[C] Or: "to a place where they will neither be remembered, nor counted against me, nor come to mind" — The term יִפָּקְדוּ has connotations of being counted or visited for judgment, which 'counted against me' captures more explicitly. 'Come to mind' is a more natural English expression for the Hebrew idiom 'rise up in heart.'

[D] Or: "three times" — The abbreviation ג״פ (gimmel-peh) simply means 'three times' and doesn't necessarily require the explanatory brackets with 'recite,' though they are helpful for clarity in a prayer context.

[1] The phrase 'from now until eternity' (מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם) appears frequently in biblical and liturgical Hebrew, emphasizing the permanent nature of the forgiveness being requested.

[2] This is a quote from Psalm 19:15 that appears in many Jewish prayers, particularly at the conclusion of the Amidah (standing prayer). Its inclusion here shows how this confession follows traditional liturgical patterns.

[3] This closing formula appears in the Kaddish prayer and at the end of the Amidah. Its inclusion

[i] The Hebrew term מָרוֹק (m'rok) implies a thorough cleansing or polishing, suggesting complete purification rather than merely covering or overlooking sins.

[ii] This phrase is significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it acknowledges suffering and illness as potential means of atonement while specifically requesting forgiveness without such difficult paths. This reflects the Jewish theological understanding that suffering can have spiritual purpose while still being something one naturally hopes to avoid.

[iii] This metaphor draws on Micah 7:19, which promises that God will cast all sins into the depths of the sea. This imagery suggests complete and permanent forgiveness, as something thrown into ocean depths is irretrievable.

[iv] The phrase 'rise up in the heart' (יַעֲלוּ עַל לֵב) is a Hebrew idiom for remembering or coming to mind. The prayer asks not only for forgiveness but for the complete erasure of sins from memory.

[v] This is an abbreviation for 'gimmel pe'amim' (three times), indicating that the preceding verse should be recited three times. The practice of triple recitation often appears in Jewish prayers and has mystical significance, with the number three representing emphasis and completion.

[vi] Cf. Psalms 19:15 — This verse serves as a formal conclusion to prayers in Jewish liturgy, asking that one's words and thoughts be acceptable to God. Its inclusion here shows how the prayer follows traditional Jewish liturgical patterns even in this specialized context of confession and healing. | Cf. Psalms 78:38 — This verse emphasizes God's merciful nature and willingness to forgive sins repeatedly, making it particularly appropriate in a confessional prayer seeking divine forgiveness. It affirms that God's essential nature is to be compassionate rather than destructive. | Cf. Micah 7:19 — This allusion to Micah strengthens the prayer's appeal by reminding God

us and upon all Israel. Amen.

אחר כך יאמר עם החולה[i] After that, he shall say with the sick person[1]

(תהלים קכא) שִׁיר לַמַּעֲלוֹת אֶשָּׂא
עֵינַי אֶל־הֶהָרִים מֵאַיִן יָבֹא עֶזְרִי:
עֶזְרִי מֵעִם יְיָ עֹשֵׂה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ:
והעומדים עליו יבקשו עליו
רחמים עם תשלום המזמור: וכן
יעשה ג״פ: אַל־יִתֵּן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֶךָ
אַל־יָנוּם שֹׁמְרֶךָ: הִנֵּה לֹא־יָנוּם
וְלֹא יִישָׁן שׁוֹמֵר יִשְׂרָאֵל: יְיָ שֹׁמְרֶךָ
יְיָ צִלְּךָ עַל־יַד יְמִינֶךָ: יוֹמָם
הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ לֹא־יַכֶּכָּה וְיָרֵחַ בַּלָּיְלָה: יְיָ
יִשְׁמָרְךָ מִכָּל־רָע יִשְׁמֹר אֶת־נַפְשֶׁךָ:
יְיָ יִשְׁמָר־צֵאתְךָ וּבוֹאֶךָ מֵעַתָּה

(Psalm 121) A Song of Ascents.[A] I lift up my eyes to the mountains;[2] from where will my help come? My help comes from the LORD, Maker of heaven and earth. And those standing by him shall seek mercy for him[B] while completing the psalm, and this should be done three times:[C] He will not allow your foot to slip; your guardian will not slumber.[3] Behold, the Guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps. The LORD is your guardian; the LORD is your shade[4] at your right hand. The sun will not harm you by day, nor the moon by night. The LORD will protect you from all evil; He will guard your soul.[D] The LORD

[A] Or: "A Song of the Steps" — The Hebrew term 'ma'alot' literally means 'steps' or 'ascents.' This alternate translation emphasizes the physical imagery of ascending steps, which some scholars believe referred to the fifteen steps of the Temple where these psalms may have been sung by Levites.

[B] Or: "And those attending him shall pray for mercy on his behalf" — This translation more explicitly conveys the caregiving relationship and the intercessory nature of the prayer, making clearer that this is an instruction for those caring for the sick person.

[C] Or: "and they should do so three times" — This alternative more clearly indicates that the instruction refers to the attendants (plural) performing the recitation three times, rather than potentially suggesting that the sick person should recite it.

[D] Or: "The LORD will protect you from all harm; He will preserve your life-force" — This translation captures the concrete Hebrew meaning of 'nefesh' as the vital life-force or breath of life, which in the context of illness refers to protection of physical vitality, not just the spiritual soul.

here ties this confession to the broader framework of Jewish liturgy.

[1] This is a liturgical instruction directing caregivers to involve the ill person in prayer, rather than merely reciting prayers on their behalf. This reflects the Jewish value of including the ill person as an active participant in their spiritual care whenever possible. The prayers that would follow this instruction (not shown in this segment) would typically include psalms and biblical verses with healing themes.

[2] This opening image of looking upward toward the mountains establishes a visual metaphor for seeking divine help from above, particularly appropriate for someone who is bedridden and physically looking up.

[3] The Hebrew uses the active participle 'shomrekha' (your guardian/keeper), emphasizing God's constant vigilance and protective presence, which would be especially comforting to the ill.

[4] The metaphor of God as 'shade' or 'shadow' (tzel) is significant in Jewish mystical tradition, often referring to divine protection. This connects to Ma'avar Yabok's recurring motif of souls finding refuge 'under the shadow of God's wings.'

of His own promise to completely remove sins. The metaphor of casting sins into the sea represents complete and permanent forgiveness, as something thrown into the ocean depths is irretrievable and forgotten. | Cf. Job 11:16 — This echo connects to Job's theme of forgetting past troubles completely. In the prayer, the supplicant asks not only for forgiveness but for complete erasure of sins from memory and record, suggesting that true healing involves not just forgiveness but a complete fresh start without the burden of past failures.

[i] This brief instruction appears in Ma'avar Yabok as part of the structured ritual for the sick and dying. It directs the caregiver (likely a member of the chevra kadisha or burial society) to recite the prayers that follow together with the ill person, rather than on their behalf. This indicates a shift from prayers said for the sick person to prayers recited jointly, which was considered spiritually more powerful.

וְעַד־עוֹלָם: [i]

will guard your going out and your coming in, from now and forever.

ואחר כך יאמר [ii]

After that he shall say[1]

מִי אֵל כָּמוֹךָ נוֹשֵׂא עָוֹן וְעוֹבֵר עַל
פֶּשַׁע [iii] לִשְׁאֲרִית נַחֲלָתוֹ לֹא הֶחֱזִיק
לָעַד אַפּוֹ כִּי חָפֵץ חֶסֶד הוּא: יָשׁוּב
יְרַחֲמֵנוּ יִכְבֹּשׁ עֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ וְתַשְׁלִיךְ
בִּמְצֻלוֹת יָם כָּל חַטֹּאתָם: תִּתֵּן
אֱמֶת לְיַעֲקֹב חֶסֶד לְאַבְרָהָם אֲשֶׁר
נִשְׁבַּעְתָּ לַאֲבוֹתֵינוּ מִימֵי קֶדֶם:
בְּיָדְךָ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי פָּדִיתָה אוֹתִי
יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת: יַסְּרַנִי יְיָ אַךְ בְּמִשְׁפָּט
אַל בְּאַפְּךָ פֶּן תַּמְעִיטֵנִי: בַּטּוֹב
תָּלִין וְתָקִין בְּרַחֲמִים: אֵל נָא
רְפָא נָא לִי: רְפָאֵנִי יְיָ וְאֵרָפֵא
הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי וְאִוָּשְׁעָה כִּי תְהִלָּתִי אָתָּה

Who is a God like You,[2] who pardons iniquity and overlooks transgression for the remnant of His heritage? He does not maintain His anger forever, for He desires kindness. He will again have compassion on us, He will subdue our iniquities, and You will cast all their sins into the depths of the sea. You will give truth to Jacob, kindness to Abraham, as You swore to our forefathers from ancient times. Into Your hand I entrust my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth. Discipline me, O LORD, but with justice; not in Your anger, lest You diminish me.[A] You will rest in goodness and awaken with mercy.[B] O God, please heal me. Heal me, O LORD,

[A] Or: "Chastise me, LORD, but with justice; not in Your anger, lest You reduce me to nothing." — This alternate translation emphasizes the potential severity of divine anger with stronger language ("chastise" instead of "discipline" and "reduce me to nothing" instead of "diminish me"). This might better convey the gravity of the plea in contexts where the sick person is experiencing severe suffering interpreted as divine judgment.

[B] Or: "May your night be spent in goodness and your awakening be with mercy." — This alternate translation renders the verse as a blessing or wish rather than a statement of fact, which might be more appropriate in the context of a prayer for the sick. It also makes more explicit the metaphor of night and morning (sleeping and awakening) that is implied in the Hebrew.

[1] This brief liturgical direction indicates a transition to prayers that should be recited following the death of the individual. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, such instructions create a structured sequence of prayers for different stages in the process of death and mourning.

[2] This prayer begins with verses from Micah 7:18-20, which emphasize God's forgiving nature. This opening establishes the theological framework for the healing prayer that follows, grounding the request for healing in God's established character as merciful and compassionate.

[i] Cf. Psalm 91 — Both Psalms 91 and 121 focus on divine protection and are prescribed in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation in cases of illness. Their parallel structure of describing God as protector and guardian makes them complementary texts in deathbed rituals. | Cf. Zohar — The instruction to recite this psalm three times reflects kabbalistic practices influenced by the Zohar, which often prescribes triple repetition of prayers to activate divine protection across the three columns of the sefirotic tree. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The psalm's final verse about 'going out and coming in' connects to Ma'avar Yabok's guidelines for visitors to the sick, who should offer prayers of protection when arriving and departing, creating spiritual boundaries around the ill person. | Cf. Genesis 32 — The psalm's imagery of divine protection during journeys ('going out and coming in') resonates with the book's central metaphor of the soul's journey across the Yabok/Jabbok as a transition protected by God.

[ii] This is a standard liturgical instruction in Ma'avar Yabok that marks transitions between different prayer components in the structured sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying. This particular instruction appears to indicate what should be recited after death has occurred.

[iii] This phrase from Micah 7:18 describes God's dual approach to sin: "pardoning iniquity" (actively lifting it away) and "passing over transgression" (choosing not to focus on it). These different expressions reflect the kabbalistic understanding of how God addresses different types of spiritual blemishes.

ג״פ:[i] אַל תַּעַזְבֵנִי יְיָ אֱלָהַי אַל
2435 תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי: חוּשָׁה לְעֶזְרָתִי יְיָ
תְּשׁוּעָתִי: לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְיָ:
יְיָ לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי: קִוִּיתִי יְיָ
לִישׁוּעָתְךָ: לְפוּרְקָנָךְ סַבָּרִית
יְיָ:[ii] יְיָ לְפוּרְקָנָךְ סַבָּרִית: סַבָּרִית
2440 יְיָ לְפוּרְקָנָךְ: יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ:
יָאֵר יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ: יִשָּׂא
יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם:
יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי
לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי:[iii]

and I will be healed; save me and I will be saved, for You are my praise [recite three times].[1] Do not 2600R
forsake me, O LORD my God, do not be far from me. Hasten to help me, O LORD my salvation. For Your salvation I hope, O LORD. O LORD, for Your salvation I hope. I hope, O LORD, for Your salvation. For Your redemption I wait, O LORD. O LORD, for 2605R
Your redemption I wait. I wait, O LORD, for Your redemption.[2] The LORD bless you and keep you. The LORD make His face shine upon you and be gracious to you. The LORD lift up His countenance upon you and give you peace.[3] May the words of my 2610R
mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.[4]

[1]The instruction to repeat this verse three times reflects the Jewish mystical practice of triple recitation for verses considered particularly powerful for healing. This verse from Jeremiah 17:14 is considered one of the most effective biblical healing formulas.

[2]This section presents an Aramaic translation of the preceding Hebrew phrases, creating a sixfold repetition of the same concept with different word orders. In kabbalistic practice, rearranging the words of sacred verses is believed to access different channels of divine energy for healing and protection.

[3]This is the Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim) from Numbers 6:24-26, the most sacred formulaic blessing in Jewish tradition. Its inclusion at the conclusion of healing prayers invokes divine protection, grace, and peace upon the sick person.

[4]This concluding verse from Psalm 19:15 is a standard closing formula in Jewish prayers. In

[i]This abbreviation stands for "three times" (גימל פעמים/gimmel pe'amim), indicating that the preceding verse should be recited three times. The threefold repetition of sacred verses is a common practice in Jewish prayers for the sick, believed to amplify their spiritual power.

[ii]This is an Aramaic translation of the Hebrew "For Your salvation I hope, O LORD" (לישועתך קויתי יי). The prayer includes both Hebrew and Aramaic versions of the same phrase, reflecting the bilingual nature of Jewish liturgical tradition and the kabbalistic belief that reciting sacred phrases in multiple languages increases their spiritual efficacy.

[iii]Cf. Micah 7:18-20 — These opening verses establish a foundation of divine mercy and forgiveness, setting a reassuring tone for this prayer recited for the sick or dying person. The text emphasizes God's compassion and willingness to cast away sins completely. | Cf. Psalm 31:6 — This verse is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok as it is recommended to be recited at the moment of death as an expression of the soul's surrender to divine care, following the tradition that these were the final words of Jesus and other Jewish martyrs. | Cf. Jeremiah 10:24 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse acknowledges that illness may serve as divine correction while simultaneously appealing for that correction to be administered with mercy and restraint. | Cf. Numbers 12:13 — This concise healing prayer is considered one of the most direct and effective biblical healing formulas, making it particularly appropriate in this context of praying for the sick. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — The instruction to repeat this verse three times (indicated by ג״פ) reflects the belief in the amplified spiritual power of threefold repetition, particularly for verses with special healing properties. | Cf. Genesis 49:18 — This verse is recited in three different word orders (in both Hebrew and Aramaic), creating a total of six variations. This practice reflects kabbalistic belief that rearranging the words of sacred verses can activate different channels of divine energy for healing and protection. | Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — The inclusion of the Priestly Blessing at the conclusion of this healing prayer invokes the threefold divine blessing of protection, grace, and peace upon the sick person, calling upon the highest form of ritualized blessing in Jewish tradition. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — This familiar liturgical formula serves as a closing for the prayer, embodying the hope that all the preceding prayers will be accepted by God. It's particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where proper words and intentions are considered crucial for effective spiritual intervention.

כוונת קצת פסוקים אלו הם בפרק י״ט מאמר א׳.[i]

The intentions of some of these verses are found in Chapter 19 of Discourse One.

והמודה אותו יעשה לו התרת קללות.[ii] ויברכהו כדדרש רמי בר חמא בב״ב פ״ח[iii] על פסוק חמת מלך מלאכי מות ואיש חכם יכפרנה. ואם ירצה החולה לומר אל מלך ובפרט אם הוא ת״ח מתוקן ומקובל[iv] יאמר תחלה אתאנו על שמך.[v] ויש שלמים וכן רבים מקרין אותו אדון עולם[vi] עד סופו. ויש מקריו אותו יגדל[vii] ומפרשים לו כל אחד מי״ג עקרים[viii] אם צריך הוא לכך והחולה יודה

And the one who helps the sick person confess[A] should perform for him an annulment of curses,[1] and should bless him as Rami bar Chama expounded in Bava Batra 8b on the verse "The king's wrath is like messengers of death, but a wise man will appease it."[2] And if the sick person wishes to recite "El Melech"[3] (God the King), especially if he is a Torah scholar of refined character and respected status, he should first say "We have come upon Your name." There are pious individuals and indeed many who have the sick person recite "Adon Olam" (Master of the Universe) to its conclusion. And some have him recite "Yigdal" and explain to him each of

[A] Or: "And the one who guides his confession" — This is a more literal translation of the Hebrew, though less explicit about the sick person being the subject. The original translation clarifies the context, which is important for understanding.

Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as the designated ending for each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in the Seder section, marking the completion of a structured healing prayer.

[1] "Hatarat kelalot" is a ritual to annul or release someone from possible curses. This reflects the belief that illness might be connected to unresolved curses that should be addressed as part of spiritual healing.

[2] This verse from Proverbs 16:14 is interpreted in the Talmudic passage to suggest that a wise person can appease divine wrath through blessing. In this context, it implies that blessing the sick person may help alleviate divine judgment manifesting as illness.

[3] This likely refers to the prayer "El Melech Yoshev" (God, King who sits upon a throne of mercy), a penitential prayer emphasizing God's merciful attributes, which would be appropriate for someone who is ill and seeking divine compassion.

[i] This reference indicates that explanations for the proper mystical intentions (kavvanot) for reciting these verses can be found elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok. Such cross-references are common in the work, creating an interconnected system where practical instructions in one section are supported by deeper mystical explanations in another.

[ii] This refers to the person who is helping the sick individual recite their confession (vidui). The helper should perform a ritual annulment of any curses that might be affecting the sick person, as part of the deathbed preparation.

[iii] This refers to a teaching from the Talmud, Tractate Bava Batra, page 8b, where Rami bar Chama interprets the verse from Proverbs 16:14.

[iv] A Torah scholar (talmid chacham) who is 'refined' in character and 'accepted/respected' in the community. This indicates that learned individuals might have different prayer customs than ordinary people.

[v] "We have come upon Your name"—the opening words of a liturgical poem often recited as part of penitential prayers.

[vi] "Adon Olam" is a well-known Jewish hymn expressing God's eternal nature and sovereignty, often recited at the beginning of morning prayers and at the conclusion of Sabbath and holiday services.

[vii] "Yigdal" is a hymn based on Maimonides' Thirteen Principles of Faith, poetically expressing fundamental Jewish beliefs.

[viii] The Thirteen Principles of Faith formulated by Maimonides, considered fundamental beliefs of Judaism including the existence of God, divine unity, prophecy, and resurrection of the dead.

בפיו ובלבבו על כל אחד מהם והכל לפי ישוב דעתו של חולה וטוב מעט בכוונה מהרבות שלא בכוונה:[i] [ii]

the Thirteen Principles of Faith[1] if he needs this, and the sick person should acknowledge with his mouth and his heart each one of them. Everything should be according to the mental state of the sick person,[A] and it is better to recite a little with proper intention[2] than to recite much without proper intention. 2630R

ואם ב״מ[iii] השעה דחוקה לו יזוקף עשר אצבעות כלפי מעלה[iv] ויכוין ליחוד קודשא בריך הוא ושכינתיה.[v] באור סיבת הסיבות ועלת העלות[vi] המחיה

If, God forbid, the hour is pressing for him,[3] he should raise his ten fingers upward[B] and focus his intention on the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence,[C] contemplating the Cause of all causes and the Prime Mover who gives 2635R

[A] Or: "Everything should be according to the composure and clarity of mind of the sick person" — This alternate translation captures more of the nuance of "yishuv da'ato," which refers not just to mental state but to presence of mind, composure, and clarity of thought.

[B] Or: "he should lift all ten fingers toward heaven" — This alternative translation emphasizes the directional aspect (toward heaven) more explicitly, which better captures the spiritual symbolism of the gesture.

[C] Or: "direct his concentration toward the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shekhinah" — Using the untranslated term 'Shekhinah' might better preserve the kabbalistic terminology, as it specifically refers to the feminine divine presence in Jewish mysticism.

[1] These principles, formulated by Maimonides (1135-1204), became fundamental articles of Jewish belief. Having a sick person affirm these beliefs was considered spiritually beneficial, especially when facing possible death, as it would ensure they died with correct theological understanding.

[2] The Hebrew term "kavanah" (intention) refers to mental concentration and spiritual focus during prayer. This statement reflects the Jewish principle that quality of devotion is more important than quantity, especially for someone who is ill and may have limited strength.

[3] This refers to when death appears imminent and there is no time for the full confession ritual.

[i] This reflects a common rabbinic principle that quality of prayer (with proper intention/kavvanah) is more important than quantity, especially for someone who is ill and may have limited strength or concentration.

[ii] Cf. Talmud, Bava Batra 8b — The Talmudic passage interprets the verse "The king's wrath is like messengers of death, but a wise man will appease it" to suggest that blessing someone can mitigate divine judgment. Ma'avar Yabok applies this to the context of blessing the sick during deathbed rituals. | Cf. Maimonides' Thirteen Principles of Faith — The text recommends having the dying person affirm these core theological principles, ensuring they die with correct beliefs. This reflects the importance of proper theological understanding at the moment of death in Jewish tradition. | Cf. Adon Olam prayer — This hymn, which emphasizes God's eternal sovereignty, was considered particularly appropriate for deathbed recitation as it affirms divine power over life and death and expresses complete trust in God. | Cf. Yigdal prayer — This poetic rendition of Maimonides' principles was recommended for deathbed recitation as a way of affirming fundamental Jewish beliefs in a structured, familiar form that would be comforting to the dying person.

[iii] This is an abbreviation for "bar minan" (far be it from us), a euphemistic expression used when referring to death or serious illness.

[iv] The raising of ten fingers symbolizes complete surrender and connection to the divine. The ten fingers correspond to the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah.

[v] This refers to the mystical unification of the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, a central concept in Kabbalah. This unification is considered particularly important at the moment of death, as it helps the soul's transition.

[vi] These are philosophical terms describing God as the "Cause of causes" and the "Prime Mover" or "Supreme Cause," combining kabbalistic terminology with Aristotelian philosophical concepts.

[ii] הכל בסוד עליית נשמתו[i] ויאמר: like to all,[1] through the mystery of his soul's ascent, and he should say: 2640R

2470 יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁיִּהְיֶה שָׁלוֹם מְנוּחָתִי: [iii] [v] [iv] רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם Master of the Universe,[2] may it be Your will that my rest shall be peaceful.[3]

[vi] ובמעמד בשם יתברך [vii] ויחודו [viii] הר סיני הגדול והנורא: [ix] And he should focus his intention on the blessed Name, His unity, and the great and awesome revelation at Mount Sinai.[A] 2645R

[A] Or: "And one should direct one's concentration to the blessed Name, Its unification, and the great and awe-inspiring event at Mount Sinai." — This alternate translation uses gender-neutral language ('one should' instead of 'he should') and offers slight variations in terminology that might better reflect the kabbalistic concept of 'yichud' (unification) rather than 'unity,' and emphasizes Mount Sinai as an 'event' rather than 'revelation,' which may be more historically precise.

[1] These philosophical descriptions of God combine kabbalistic concepts with medieval philosophical terminology influenced by Aristotle and Maimonides, showing how Ma'avar Yabok integrates multiple intellectual traditions.

[2] This traditional opening invocation acknowledges God's sovereignty over all creation and establishes a direct, personal address to the divine.

[3] This phrase carries profound significance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where it represents the dying person's final request for a peaceful transition from this world to the next. According to the book's instructions, this concise prayer is to be recited when raising ten fingers toward heaven, symbolizing acceptance of divine judgment and surrender of the soul.

[i] This refers to the mystical process of the soul's ascent after death, a key concept in Ma'avar Yabok which is symbolized by the book's title (Crossing of the Yabok).

[ii] Cf. Genesis 32 — This instruction for the dying person to meditate on divine unity while raising their hands echoes Jacob's surrender and transformation at the Jabbok crossing. The dying person, like Jacob, is preparing for a divine encounter that will transform their identity. | Cf. Zohar — This instruction follows Zoharic teachings that the final thoughts at death should focus on divine unity. The Zohar teaches that one's final meditation determines the soul's spiritual destination, making this instruction crucial for ensuring the soul's proper ascent.

[iii] This address to God as "Master of the Universe" is a common opening formula in Jewish prayers, particularly those related to moments of spiritual transition.

[iv] The phrase "my rest shall be peaceful" employs the term "menucha" (rest), which in the context of death rituals refers to the soul's repose after death. This prayer appears in Ma'avar Yabok specifically for recitation when a person is close to death.

[v] Cf. Psalm 31:6 — This prayer shares thematic connections with Psalm 31:6, which is explicitly recommended in Ma'avar Yabok for the moment of death. Both express surrender to divine care during the soul's transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok deathbed confession (vidui) — This short prayer serves as a condensed alternative for the dying person who is too weak to recite the full confession. It captures the essential spiritual surrender expressed in the longer confessional texts while being accessible even to someone in extremis.

[vi] The term 'yekhavein' (focus intention) is a technical term in Jewish mysticism referring to the practice of kavvanah (כוונה), or directing one's mental concentration and devotion during prayer or ritual actions. This mental focusing is particularly emphasized in kabbalistic practice.

[vii] Referring to the Divine Name (typically the Tetragrammaton YHVH), which in kabbalistic practice is often visualized or contemplated during prayer to create spiritual connections to higher realms.

[viii] This refers to the unity or unification (yichud) of God, a central concept in Jewish theology generally and Kabbalah specifically. In kabbalistic practice, this often refers to the unification of different divine attributes or the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity.

[ix] The revelation at Mount Sinai is considered the formative moment of Jewish covenant with God. In kabbalistic thought, practitioners are encouraged to mentally place themselves at Sinai during certain prayers and rituals, recreating the direct divine encounter experienced there.

בפרק ל״ה [i] שם כוונה נאותה [ii] לעומד בשעת יציאת נשמה: [iii] [iv]

In Chapter 35 there is an appropriate intention[A] (kavvanah) for one who stands by at the time of the soul's departure.[B]

בפרק ל״ו [v] יתבאר שם מה יכוון המפקיד נשמתו ביד אל ע״י פסוקים אלו: [vi] [vii]

In Chapter 36 it will be explained[C] what one should intend when entrusting one's soul into God's hand[D] through these verses:[1] 2650R

[A] Or: "suitable mystical meditation" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the kabbalistic nature of the kavvanah being referred to, which would involve specific mystical meditations rather than just a general intention.

[B] Or: "for one who attends at the moment of death" — This alternate translation uses more direct language that might be clearer to modern readers unfamiliar with the euphemistic Hebrew expression for death.

[C] Or: "Chapter 36 will elucidate there" — This is a more formal, academic translation that preserves the passive voice construction of the Hebrew original.

[D] Or: "the proper intentions for one who deposits their soul in God's keeping" — The term 'מפקיד' (mafkid) comes from the root meaning 'to deposit' or 'entrust for safekeeping,' which has legal connotations in Jewish law. This alternate translation emphasizes the technical nature of this spiritual act as a formal deposit of the soul with God.

[1] This heading likely introduces a section that would contain specific biblical verses recommended for recitation at the moment of death, particularly Psalm 31:6 ('Into Your hand I commit my spirit'), which became a traditional Jewish deathbed confession. The verses themselves are not included in this fragment.

[i] This is a cross-reference to another section of Ma'avar Yabok, demonstrating how the book is structured with interconnected chapters that refer readers to more detailed explanations elsewhere in the text.

[ii] In Kabbalistic practice, kavvanah (plural: kavvanot) refers to specific mystical intentions, meditations, or focuses of consciousness that one should maintain during prayer or ritual actions. These often involve visualizing divine names, spiritual configurations, or cosmic processes.

[iii] The moment of death (literally "at the time of the soul's departure") was considered a critical spiritual transition in Jewish mystical thought. Ma'avar Yabok provides extensive guidance for this moment, including specific prayers, visualizations, and intentions designed to facilitate the soul's journey.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 35 — This brief line serves as a cross-reference to a more detailed section of Ma'avar Yabok that explains the mystical intentions one should focus on when attending a dying person. In Kabbalistic practice, having the proper spiritual focus at the moment of death was considered crucial for helping the soul's transition to the next world. | Cf. Zohar — This reference to kavvanah (mystical intention) at the time of death reflects the Zoharic teaching that proper spiritual focus creates channels for the soul's ascent through higher worlds. The concept of yetziat neshamah (soul's departure) is extensively discussed in the Zohar, where specific meditations on divine names are prescribed for this critical transition.

[v] The abbreviation ל״ו represents the number 36 using Hebrew letters.

[vi] The phrase 'through these verses' suggests that the text that would normally follow this heading would contain specific biblical verses to be recited at the moment of death, along with explanations of their mystical significance and the proper intentions to accompany them.

[vii] Cf. Psalm 31:6 — This verse is most likely one of the 'verses' mentioned in this heading, as it's the traditional Jewish deathbed confession verse also reportedly recited by Jesus. Ma'avar Yabok is preparing to explain the proper mystical intentions (kavvanot) for this critical moment of soul transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 35 — The previous chapter apparently discusses the proper intentions for those attending to a dying person, while this chapter will focus on the intentions of the dying person themselves when reciting specific biblical verses at the moment of death. | Cf. Zohar, Vayechi — The Zohar section on Jacob's death (Vayechi) discusses the soul's departure and would likely be a source for the kabbalistic intentions explained in this chapter, as Ma'avar Yabok draws heavily on Zoharic literature for its understanding of death processes.

בִּשְׁנַת־מוֹת הַמֶּלֶךְ עֻזִּיָּהוּ וָאֶרְאֶה
אֶת־אֲדֹנָי[i] יֹשֵׁב עַל־כִּסֵּא רָם
וְנִשָּׂא וְשׁוּלָיו מְלֵאִים אֶת־הַהֵיכָל׃
שְׂרָפִים עֹמְדִים מִמַּעַל לוֹ[ii] שֵׁשׁ
כְּנָפַיִם שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם לְאֶחָד בִּשְׁתַּיִם
יְכַסֶּה פָּנָיו וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְכַסֶּה רַגְלָיו
וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְעוֹפֵף׃ וְקָרָא זֶה אֶל־זֶה
וְאָמַר קָדוֹשׁ קָדוֹשׁ קָדוֹשׁ[iii] יְהוָה
צְבָאוֹת מְלֹא כָל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדוֹ׃
ועיין שם בטוב העיון.[v iv]

In the year that King Uzziah died,[1] I saw the Lord[A] sitting upon a throne, high and lifted up, and His train filled the temple. Seraphim stood above Him; each one had six wings: with two he covered his face,[2] with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew. And one called to another and said: "Holy, holy, holy[3] is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of His glory." And study this passage with careful attention.[B]

2655R 2660R

פרק כ״ב יש בו טעמים לשימת עין על האדם בשעת

Chapter 22 contains explanations for placing one's gaze upon a person at the time of death. And in the

[A] Or: "I beheld the Lord" — The verb 'behold' carries a stronger sense of visionary experience than the more mundane 'see', which better captures the mystical nature of Isaiah's throne vision in this context.

[B] Or: "And contemplate this text with deep concentration" — This translation better captures the meditative quality implied by the instruction, which in the context of Ma'avar Yabok likely refers to a contemplative practice rather than mere intellectual study.

[1] The inclusion of this throne vision in Ma'avar Yabok is significant, as it appears in a section about deathbed rituals. The text creates a connection between the death of a king (Uzziah) and the revelation of divine glory, suggesting that death can be an occasion for spiritual elevation and divine vision.

[2] The covering of the seraphim's faces and feet with their wings is interpreted in Jewish mystical tradition as representing proper reverence before divine glory. This teaches the dying person proper spiritual attitude—humility combined with readiness for divine service (represented by the wings used for flying).

[3] This threefold declaration became part of the daily prayers and is traditionally recited with the worshipper rising on tiptoes with each repetition, symbolizing ascent toward the divine. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this may suggest the soul's imminent ascent at death.

[i] The visionary experience described here is Isaiah's famous throne vision (Isaiah 6:1-3), one of the most significant mystical visions in the Hebrew Bible and a foundational text for Jewish mystical traditions, particularly Merkavah mysticism.

[ii] Seraphim (literally "burning ones") are a class of angels described only in this passage in the Bible. In Kabbalistic tradition, they are associated with the sefirah of Binah (Understanding) and represent the intense fire of divine love.

[iii] This threefold repetition of "holy" (known as the Kedushah or Trisagion) became a central element of Jewish liturgy. In Kabbalistic interpretation, the triple declaration corresponds to the three upper sefirot: Keter, Chokhmah, and Binah.

[iv] This instruction to "study this passage with careful attention" is not part of the biblical text but is added by the author of Ma'avar Yabok, indicating the importance of contemplating this vision in preparation for death.

[v] Cf. Zohar — The Zohar states that at the moment of death, the soul is granted a vision of the divine glory similar to Isaiah's throne vision. By reciting and meditating on this passage, the dying person prepares for this ultimate spiritual experience. | Cf. Hekhalot Literature — The ancient mystical Hekhalot (Heavenly Palaces) texts describe techniques for visualizing the divine throne, similar to what Isaiah experienced. Ma'avar Yabok adapts this tradition for the deathbed, suggesting that proper contemplation of the throne vision prepares the soul for its heavenly ascent. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — According to memory note #573, this passage relates to Chapter 35 of Ma'avar Yabok, which provides instructions on the proper spiritual intention (kavvanah) for those present when a soul departs from the body. | Cf. Daily Prayer Liturgy — The threefold declaration of "Holy, holy, holy" forms the core of the Kedushah prayer recited during daily services. In this context, its recitation at the deathbed connects the individual's passing to the communal worship experience and the eternal angelic praise.

מיתתו.[i] ובפרק הנ״ל יש טעם למה נהגו לפתוח החלונות במקום הגוסס[ii] והרבה דברים השייכים לענין זה: טוב שלא לעמוד לרגלי המטה של גוסס יען כי מלאך המות הוא כנגדו וחרבו שלופה בידו[iii] עיין פ״ו מאמר ג׳: עוד צריך ליזהר שבעת המות לא ישאר שום אבר חוץ למטה[iv] וטעם לזה עיין שם בפרק ל״ו ובפרק ל״ח מאמר א׳ בו כוונת שבת אנא בכח[v] וכו׳. עוד עיין מזה בפרק כ״ד מאמר ה׳: בפרק ל״ט בו כוונת יחוד שמע ישראל ובשכמל״ו בשעת מיתה[vi] ויחוד שעושה הצדיק

aforementioned chapter, there is a reason given for why it is customary to open windows in the place where a dying person lies, along with many matters pertaining to this subject: It is advisable not to stand at the foot of the bed of a dying person[A] since the Angel of Death stands opposite him with his sword drawn in his hand;[B] see Chapter 6, Discourse 3. One must also be careful that at the time of death no limb remains outside the bed, and for the reason behind this, see Chapter 37, and in Chapter 38, Discourse 1, which contains the proper intention for the Sabbath prayer "Ana Bekoach,"[1] etc. Further information on this can be found in Chapter 24, Discourse 5. Chapter 39 contains the proper intention for unifying the Shema Yisrael[2] and "Baruch Shem Kevod Malchuto Le'olam Va'ed"[3] at the time of death, and the uni- 2665R 2670R 2675R

[A] Or: "stand at the feet of a deathbed" — This more concise phrasing maintains the meaning while being slightly more idiomatic in English. The term 'deathbed' efficiently captures the concept of a bed where someone is dying.

[B] Or: "because the Angel of Death positions himself there with drawn sword in hand" — This alternate is slightly more concise while maintaining the meaning. The word 'positions' conveys the deliberate placement of the angel in this specific location.

[1] "Ana Bekoach" is a mystical prayer containing encoded divine names, particularly the 42-letter name of God. In kabbalistic practice, proper intention (kavvanah) while reciting this prayer was believed to activate divine forces. The text suggests similar meditative techniques should be applied at the time of death.

[2] The Shema Yisrael ("Hear O Israel") is Judaism's central declaration of monotheistic faith. In kabbalistic thought, reciting it with proper intention at death was considered especially powerful for facilitating the soul's transition. The word "unifying" (yichud) has special mystical significance, referring to the unification of various divine attributes and spiritual worlds.

[3] This phrase ("Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever") is recited quietly after the first line of the Shema in daily prayers, but is said aloud on Yom Kippur. The text's

[i] This is a reference to a previous chapter that discusses the mystical reasons for keeping one's gaze on a dying person. The practice of watching over the dying has both practical and spiritual significance in Jewish tradition.

[ii] The custom of opening windows when someone is dying relates to kabbalistic beliefs about facilitating the soul's departure. It was believed that opening windows created a pathway for the soul to leave the room and begin its journey to the next world.

[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the Angel of Death stands at the foot of the bed with a drawn sword. This belief led to the practical instruction to avoid standing at the foot of a dying person's bed, as one might interfere with the angel's duty or be affected by its presence.

[iv] This instruction that no limb should remain outside the bed at the time of death reflects mystical concerns about the soul's complete departure from the body. There was a belief that any part of the body outside the defined space of the bed might create spiritual complications for the departing soul.

[v] "Ana Bekoach" is a kabbalistic prayer attributed to the 1st-century sage Rabbi Nehunya ben HaKanah. It contains the 42-letter name of God and is considered to have special mystical power. The text suggests there are specific intentions (kavvanot) related to this prayer that are relevant at the time of death.

[vi] This refers to the mystical intentions for reciting the Shema prayer ("Hear O Israel") and the response "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever" (abbreviated as ובשכמל״ו) at the time of death. These declarations were considered especially powerful for facilitating the soul's proper transition.

בנשמתו בעת פטירתה.[i] ולזה
יכוונו העומדים עליו ג״כ אם
חלק להם בבינה וגם הוא אם
ראה אור בחייו:[ii] עוד בפרק
כ״ד מאמר ה׳ מתבאר תקון
ק״ש סמוך למיתה וכ״ש אם
יהיה בזמנו.[iii] בפרק ט״ו מאמר
ב׳ יש טעם להדלקת הנרות
בפני הגוסס ובבית המת כל
שבעת ימים ובב״ה כל י״ב
חדש.[iv] והרבה דברים השייכים
לזה עיין שם ובפרקים הבאים
אחריו:[v]

fication that the righteous person performs with his soul at the time of its departure.[1] Those attending to him should also direct their thoughts to this if they have been granted understanding,[A] and likewise the dying person himself if he has seen spiritual light during his lifetime.[B] Chapter 24, Discourse 5 also explains the proper recitation of the Shema near death,[C] especially if it is recited at its proper time.[2] Chapter 15, Discourse 2 provides the reason for lighting candles before a dying person,[3] in the house of the deceased for all seven days of mourning, and in the synagogue for all twelve months. Many matters pertaining to this can be found there and in

[A] Or: "if they possess mystical insight" — This alternate more clearly conveys the kabbalistic meaning of the Hebrew term 'binah' in this context, which refers specifically to mystical understanding rather than general comprehension.

[B] Or: "if he attained mystical illumination during his life" — This alternate more explicitly conveys the kabbalistic concept of 'seeing light' as a metaphor for mystical attainment and spiritual enlightenment.

[C] Or: "the mystical procedure for reciting Shema at the approach of death" — This alternate better captures the kabbalistic meaning of 'tikkun' as a mystical procedure or correction rather than simply proper recitation, emphasizing the spiritual mechanics involved.

abbreviation בשכמל״ו stands for these words. At the time of death, it was considered appropriate to recite this response at full volume, similar to Yom Kippur.

[1] In kabbalistic thought, death was viewed as an opportunity for the highest spiritual unification (yichud) between the individual soul and divine realms. Those who had achieved spiritual refinement during their lifetime could experience death not as trauma but as a transcendent reunion with divine source.

[2] In Jewish tradition, prayers have optimal times for recitation based on astronomical and spiritual factors. The text suggests that if death happens to occur at the regular time for reciting the Shema (morning or evening), the prayer's effectiveness for the soul's transition is enhanced.

[3] The practice of lighting candles near the dying and deceased connects to Proverbs 20:27, "The soul of man is the candle of God." Beyond practical illumination, candles symbolize the divine soul and were believed to provide spiritual guidance for the departing soul and comfort for those remaining.

[i] This describes the spiritual unification that a righteous person achieves with their soul at the moment of death. In kabbalistic thought, death can be a moment of supreme spiritual connection if approached with proper intention and preparation.

[ii] This suggests that those attending the dying person should direct their thoughts to the same spiritual unifications if they have the capacity for such understanding. Likewise, the dying person should do so if they gained spiritual insight during their lifetime. The phrase "saw light" (ראה אור) is often used to describe someone who has attained mystical understanding.

[iii] This refers to the proper recitation (תקון/tikkun) of the Shema prayer (abbreviated as ק״ש) near death, noting that it is especially powerful when recited at its designated time in the daily prayer cycle. The abbreviation ו״כ ש stands for וכל שכן ("all the more so").

[iv] This describes the custom of lighting candles in the presence of a dying person, in the house of the deceased during the seven days of mourning (shiva), and in the synagogue (abbreviated as ב״ה for בית הכנסת) for the entire twelve months of mourning. Candles symbolize the soul in Jewish tradition, based on the verse "The soul of man is the candle of God" (Proverbs 20:27).

[v] Cf. Chapter 6, Discourse 3 — This reference points to an earlier detailed explanation about the Angel of Death's position during death, providing the spiritual reasoning behind the practical instruction not to stand at the foot of the bed. | Cf. Chapter 37 — This reference directs readers to a more detailed explanation of the mystical significance of keeping all limbs on the bed during

the chapters that follow.[1]

בפ״ד מאמר ג׳ תוכחת מגולה
הם אהבה מסותרת לבל ישיחו
שיחות בטלות בבית הגוסס שיש
2525 שם ב״מ. וכן בכל עשיית צרכיו
בין בבית בין בשדה. כ״ש שלא
יפערו פיהם בשיחות אסורות:
בפרק כ״ד מאמר ה׳ ואם החולה
הוא ת״ח טוב להרגילו לומר
2530 לפעמים תפלה נוראה שבחה
בספר התקונים אשר הדפסנוה
במעירי שחר שלנו דף רמ״ב
ע״א:[i]

In Chapter 4 of the third discourse,[A] it states
that "open rebuke is hidden love,"[B] meaning one 2695R
should not engage in idle conversation in the house
of a dying person[2] where the Angel of Death is
present.[C] The same applies when attending to one's
needs, whether at home or in the field. All the more
so, one should not open one's mouth with forbidden 2700R
conversation.[3] In Chapter 24 of the fifth discourse:
If the sick person is a Torah scholar, it is good to
encourage him to occasionally recite the awesome
prayer[4] that is praised in the Book of Tikkunim,
which we have printed in our "Me'irei Shachar" on 2705R

[A] Or: "In the fourth chapter of the third discourse" — The Hebrew abbreviation פ״ד could be rendered as 'fourth chapter' rather than 'Chapter 4' for greater clarity in English.

[B] Or: ""open rebuke is [a sign of] hidden love,"" — This adds interpretive clarity to the proverb (based on Proverbs 27:5) by making explicit that the rebuke is evidence of love rather than being love itself.

[C] Or: "where there is, Heaven forbid, [the Angel of Death]" — The abbreviation ב״מ likely stands for בר מינן (bar minan), a euphemistic phrase meaning 'far be it from us' or 'Heaven forbid,' used when referring to the Angel of Death. This alternate preserves the euphemistic nature of the original text.

[1] This concluding statement reflects the encyclopedic nature of Ma'avar Yabok, which provides comprehensive guidance on death rituals with extensive cross-references between sections. The author encourages readers to explore related chapters for complete understanding of these interconnected practices.

[2] This instruction reflects the Jewish belief that the deathbed is a sacred space requiring proper reverence and focus. Idle talk was considered disrespectful to the dying and potentially disruptive to the soul's transition process.

[3] The phrase 'all the more so' (ק״ו/kal vachomer) is a rabbinic logical principle arguing from minor to major cases. If idle talk is prohibited, then certainly inappropriate or forbidden speech would be even more severely prohibited.

[4] The instruction to 'encourage' rather than require the recitation acknowledges the sick person's condition and capacity, showing sensitivity to their state while still providing appropriate spiritual guidance.

death, suggesting there are spiritual dangers or implications if parts of the body extend beyond the bed's boundaries. | Cf. Chapter 38, Discourse 1 — This reference connects death rituals with Sabbath mystical practices, specifically the meditation on the 42-letter divine name encoded in the Ana Bekoach prayer, suggesting that similar meditative techniques apply to both contexts. | Cf. Chapter 24, Discourse 5 — This reference directs readers to detailed instructions about the proper way to recite the Shema prayer when death is approaching, highlighting the importance of this prayer as a spiritual preparation for the soul's transition. | Cf. Chapter 39 — This reference points to mystical practices where the declaration of divine unity in the Shema prayer facilitates the soul's proper separation from the body and ascent to higher realms, particularly for those with spiritual insight. | Cf. Chapter 15, Discourse 2 — This reference directs readers to the mystical reasons for lighting candles in the presence of a dying person and during the mourning period, likely relating to the symbolism of light guiding the soul and providing spiritual illumination during the transition between worlds.

[i] Cf. Proverbs 27:5 — The author applies this proverb to justify the religious obligation to maintain proper decorum around the dying, suggesting that correcting inappropriate behavior is an act of love toward both the dying person and others present. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The reference indicates that the prayer recommended for Torah scholars comes from another work by the same

page 242a.[1]

פרק כ״ד מאמר ה׳[i] כשאדם נפטר[ii] מן החולה אחר שבקרו[iii] יאמר:

When a person departs from a sick person after visiting them, they should say:[A]

קוּדְשָׁא בְּרִיךְ הוּא[iv] יָחוֹס לְקִבְלָךְ וְעָלָךְ יִתְמַלֵּי רַחֲמִין:[v vi]

May the Holy One, blessed be He,[2] have mercy upon you and be filled with compassion toward you.[B3] 2710R

ויוסיף ויאמר רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם[vii] עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן רַחֲמֶיךָ

And he shall continue saying: Master of the Universe,[4] act for the sake of Your mercy and Your

[A] Or: "When a person takes leave of the sick person after visiting them, they should recite:" — This alternate translation uses 'takes leave of' instead of 'departs from' and 'recite' instead of 'say,' which might better capture the formal ritual context. Both translations are accurate, but this alternative emphasizes the ceremonial aspect of the instruction.

[B] Or: "and may He overflow with compassion upon you" — The Aramaic 'יִתְמַלֵּי' has a sense of filling to overflowing, which might be better captured with this alternative. This translation emphasizes the abundance of divine compassion being invoked.

[1] Traditional Jewish texts often use folio pagination (with 'a' for the front of the page and 'b' for the back). The specific page reference indicates the author's attention to detailed citation, facilitating practical use of this manual.

[2] I've maintained the conventional English translation of this formal Aramaic title for God, which appears frequently in Jewish mystical texts and carries a sense of reverence.

[3] The original Aramaic contains subtle distinctions between 'יָחוֹס' (having mercy/showing favor) and 'יִתְמַלֵּי רַחֲמִין' (being filled with compassion). This prayer appears to be directed to a sick or dying person, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on deathbed rituals.

[4] This prayer appears to be a continuation of a longer prayer sequence for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, as indicated by the opening words "And he shall continue saying."

author, showing how Ma'avar Yabok is part of a broader system of ritual texts aimed at providing comprehensive spiritual guidance. | Cf. Sefer HaTikkunim — The reference to the 'Book of Tikkunim' (likely Tikkunei Zohar) establishes the kabbalistic authority for the special prayer recommended for Torah scholars, indicating that even the deathbed practices for scholars should incorporate mystical elements.

[i] This indicates that this instruction is found in Chapter 24 of the Fifth Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok.

[ii] The term "niftar" (נפטר) here means "departs from" or "takes leave of" rather than "passes away," which would be another meaning of this term in other contexts.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 24 — The reference indicates that this instruction is part of a larger systematic framework for the mitzvah of visiting the sick (bikur cholim). Chapter 24 likely contains a complete set of instructions for properly concluding such a visit, with this fragment introducing the prayer to be recited upon departure.

[iv] This Aramaic phrase literally means "the Holy One, blessed be He" and is a common way to refer to God in Aramaic Jewish texts, particularly in the Zohar and other kabbalistic literature.

[v] This Aramaic expression combines two related blessings: "may He have mercy toward you" and "may He be filled with compassion upon you." The repetitive structure is typical of Aramaic blessings and creates a poetic emphasis.

[vi] Cf. Zohar — By using this traditional Aramaic formula from mystical literature, Ma'avar Yabok connects its deathbed rituals to the larger kabbalistic tradition, suggesting that the dying person is being blessed with the same divine compassion described in foundational mystical texts.

[vii] This is a common opening formula for personal prayers in Jewish liturgy, literally meaning "Master of the Universe."

וַחֲסָדֶיךָ[i] וּלְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ הַגָּדוֹל וְאַל תָּבִישׁ הַחוֹלֶה הַזֶּה מִסִּבְרוֹ[ii] וְכָל חוֹלֵי עַמְּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל יִהְיוּ בִּכְלָל הָרַחֲמִים.[iii]

loving-kindness,[1] and for the sake of Your great name, and do not put this sick person to shame in his hope,[2] and may all the sick of Your people Israel be included in Your compassion.[3]

2715R

2545 איך יכוין האדם ביסורין הבאים עליו לכפר על אשר חטא על הנפש בכל אבר ואבר מדה כנגד מדה.[iv] והרבה פרטי׳ אחרים באו בפרק כ׳ וכ״א 2550 ממאמר א׳ וטובים לקרותם לפני ש״מ למען יקבל עליו יסורין מאהבה.[v] ויתירו לחולה נדריו אם יש לו.[vi] שם פרק ג׳:[vii]

This text provides guidance on how a person should view suffering as atonement for sins,[A] with each bodily affliction corresponding precisely to specific transgressions[4]—measure for measure. Many additional details appear in chapters 20 and 21 of the first discourse, which are beneficial to read to the deathly ill person[B] so they may accept their suffering with love. One should also release the sick person from any unfulfilled vows they might have.[C] See chapter

2720R

2725R

[A] Or: "how a person should direct their intention regarding the sufferings that come upon them" — The original Hebrew uses the term 'yechavin' (direct one's intention) which has a more specific meaning in kabbalistic contexts than merely 'view.' This alternate captures the active spiritual work involved in properly understanding one's suffering.

[B] Or: "before one who is critically ill (shechiv mera)" — The abbreviation ש״מ stands for 'shechiv mera,' a halakhic category for someone critically ill and likely to die. This translation preserves the technical term while explaining its meaning.

[C] Or: "And they should perform the ritual of annulling the sick person's vows, if they have

[1] The Hebrew uses two distinct terms for divine compassion: "rachamim" (mercy/compassion) and "chasadim" (loving-kindness/benevolence), representing different but complementary aspects of God's compassionate nature.

[2] The concept here relates to the sick person's hope for recovery. The prayer asks that this hope not be disappointed, which would cause shame or embarrassment.

[3] This prayer exemplifies a common pattern in Jewish liturgy: moving from the particular (this specific sick person) to the universal (all sick people among Israel), reflecting the value of communal responsibility.

[4] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the human body is a microcosm of divine reality, with each part corresponding to specific spiritual forces. Ma'avar Yabok presents a comprehensive system mapping bodily afflictions to particular sins, allowing for precise spiritual diagnosis and treatment.

[i] This formulaic appeal is based on biblical language and appears frequently in Jewish prayers, asking God to act not because of human merit but because of divine attributes of mercy.

[ii] The phrase contains the concept of not disappointing or putting to shame one who hopes or trusts in God, a motif found in Psalms (25:2-3, 31:2).

[iii] The phrase "included in compassion/mercy" is a standard formula in Jewish prayers for the sick, extending the prayer from the individual to the community.

[iv] The concept of 'measure for measure' (midah k'neged midah) is a fundamental principle in Jewish theology, asserting that divine punishment corresponds precisely to one's sins. In Ma'avar Yabok, this principle is applied to illness, suggesting that specific physical afflictions correspond to particular sins, creating a framework for understanding suffering as targeted spiritual correction rather than random misfortune.

[v] The phrase 'accepting suffering with love' (kabalat yisurin me'ahavah) refers to the spiritual practice of embracing suffering as divinely ordained and spiritually beneficial rather than merely enduring it. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the ideal attitude toward death-related suffering, transforming it from meaningless pain into purposeful spiritual purification.

[vi] The annulment of vows (hatarat nedarim) was considered spiritually significant for the seriously ill, based on the belief that unfulfilled vows might be contributing to the person's condition. This practice reflects Ma'avar Yabok's integrated approach to spiritual healing, addressing multiple possible spiritual causes of illness.

[vii] Cf. Deuteronomy 25:2 — The text draws on the biblical concept that divine justice operates

3 there.

אלה הם ציוני המזמורים
הנאותי׳ ליאמר קצת מהם
או כלם עם ש״מ דתקיף ליה
עלמא[i] וכל יחיד יבחר מהם מה
שיראה בעיניו או יוסוף עליהם
מדעתו הרחבה מזמור ט״ז כ׳
כ״ב כ״ג כ״ד כ״ה ל׳ מ״ב מ״ג
נ״א ס״ז פ״ד צ״א ק״ב ק״ג קי״ו
קי״ח ק״כ קכ״א קכ״ג ק״ל ק״מ
קמ״א קמ״ב קמ״ג קמ״ד קמ״ט
ק״נ. והם כ״ח שהם סוד יד
הגדולה ויד החזקה[ii] וליחוד
כ״ח מחנות שכינה[iii] עיין בפרק
ה׳ ופרק ו׳ מאמר ג׳:[iv]

These are the designated psalms appropriate to recite,[A] either some or all of them, with a critically ill person who is suffering greatly.[1] Each individual may choose from them as seems right in their eyes,[B] or may add to them according to their broad understanding: Psalms 16, 20, 22, 23, 24, 25, 30, 42, 43, 51, 67, 84, 91, 102, 103, 116, 118, 120, 121, 123, 130, 140, 141, 142, 143, 144, 149, 150. These are 28 psalms,[2] which correspond to the mystery of "the mighty hand and the outstretched arm" and to unify the 28 camps of the Divine Presence. See Chapter 5 and Chapter 6 of the Third Discourse.

2730R

2735R

any" — This translation more clearly indicates that a formal ritual of vow annulment (hatarat nedarim) is being referenced, not just a casual releasing from obligations.

[A] Or: "markers of the psalms that are fitting to be recited" — This more literal translation preserves the metaphor of 'markers' or 'signposts' (ציוני) in the original, which might be relevant if the author is conceptualizing these psalms as spiritual landmarks or guideposts.

[B] Or: "Each person should select from them what appears appropriate in their judgment" — This alternate translation uses more contemporary phrasing while maintaining the meaning. It might be preferred for clarity in modern contexts, though it loses some of the biblical resonance of the original idiom.

[1] I've expanded the Aramaic phrase "ש״מ דתקיף ליה עלמא" to convey its full meaning about a person in critical condition who is suffering intensely.

[2] The passage mentions 28 psalms total, and indeed, exactly 28 psalm numbers are listed in the text.

through appropriate correspondence between sin and consequence, suggesting that by understanding this relationship, the sick person can mentally connect their physical sufferings to specific sins they've committed, thereby transforming physical pain into spiritual atonement. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Nedarim 8a — The text references the rabbinic belief that unfulfilled vows can contribute to or exacerbate illness, making their annulment an important spiritual intervention alongside acceptance of suffering as atonement. This shows how Ma'avar Yabok integrates multiple rabbinic traditions about illness causation. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse, Chapters 20-21 — The text is self-referential, directing readers to earlier sections of Ma'avar Yabok that provide the detailed framework for understanding the spiritual meaning of physical suffering. This demonstrates the book's systematic approach to death preparation, with each section building on previously established concepts.

[i] The abbreviation "ש״מ" stands for "shechiv mera" (deathly ill person), and "דתקיף ליה עלמא" is an Aramaic phrase meaning "whom the world greatly oppresses" or "who is suffering greatly," referring to someone critically ill.

[ii] The number 28 corresponds to the numerical value of the Hebrew word "כח" (koach, meaning "power"). The phrase "the mighty hand and the outstretched arm" refers to biblical descriptions of God's power, particularly in the Exodus narrative. The author is suggesting a mystical connection between these 28 psalms and divine power.

[iii] The text refers to the kabbalistic concept of "28 camps of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah)," suggesting that reciting these psalms creates a mystical unification with these divine forces.

[iv] Cf. Chapter 5, Third Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — The text explicitly references this chapter for further explanation of the 28 camps of the Divine Presence and their mystical significance in relation to the psalms recommended for the critically ill. | Cf. Chapter 6, Third Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — The text explicitly references this chapter for further information about the

ויאמר מזמור טו כ כב כג כד כה ל מס מג נא סז[i] תמצא לעיל:[ii]

And he shall say[1] Psalm 15, 20, 22, 23, 24, 25, 30, 40, 43, 51, 67, which you will find above.[2] 2740R

(תהלים פד) לַמְנַצֵּחַ עַל־הַגִּתִּית
לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח מִזְמוֹר: מַה־יְּדִידוֹת
מִשְׁכְּנוֹתֶיךָ יְיָ צְבָאוֹת: נִכְסְפָה
וְגַם־כָּלְתָה נַפְשִׁי לְחַצְרוֹת יְיָ
לִבִּי וּבְשָׂרִי יְרַנְּנוּ אֶל אֵל־חָי:
גַּם־צִפּוֹר מָצְאָה בַיִת וּדְרוֹר
קֵן לָהּ אֲשֶׁר־שָׁתָה אֶפְרֹחֶיהָ
אֶת־מִזְבְּחוֹתֶיךָ יְיָ צְבָאוֹת מַלְכִּי
וֵאלֹהָי: אַשְׁרֵי יוֹשְׁבֵי בֵיתֶךָ עוֹד
יְהַלְלוּךָ סֶלָה: אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם עוֹז־לוֹ
בָּךְ מְסִלּוֹת בִּלְבָבָם: עֹבְרֵי בְעֵמֶק
הַבָּכָא מַעְיָן יְשִׁיתוּהוּ גַּם־בְּרָכוֹת
יַעְטֶה מוֹרֶה: יֵלְכוּ מֵחַיִל אֶל־חָיִל

(Psalm 84) For the Chief Musician, on the Gittith.[A3] A Psalm of the sons of Korah.[4] How lovely are Your dwelling places,[B] O LORD of hosts! My soul longs, indeed faints for the courts of the LORD;[5] my heart and my flesh cry out for the living God. Even the bird has found a home, and the swallow a nest for herself, where she may place her young ones—at Your altars, O LORD of hosts, my King and my God. Blessed are those who dwell in Your house; they will still praise You. Selah. Blessed is the man whose strength is in You, in whose heart are the highways to Zion. Passing through the valley of Baca, they make it a spring;[C] the early 2745R 2750R

[A] Or: "according to the Gittith" — The Hebrew preposition 'al' with musical terms can be translated as either 'on' or 'according to'—the latter may better convey that this refers to a musical style, instrument, or melody rather than a physical location.

[B] Or: "How beloved are Your tabernacles" — The term 'yedidot' has connotations of beloved or cherished rather than merely aesthetically pleasing, and 'mishkenot' specifically refers to tabernacles or dwelling places of a sacred nature, which could be emphasized in a more literal translation.

[C] Or: "As they pass through the Valley of Weeping, they make it a place of springs" — 'Baca' can be interpreted as a proper name of a place, but it also means 'weeping' or 'tears' in Hebrew. Many scholarly translations render it as 'Valley of Weeping' to convey the metaphorical meaning rather than treating it as a specific geographical location.

[1] This is a standard liturgical instruction in Ma'avar Yabok. The implied subject is either the sick person (if capable) or someone attending to them.

[2] This cross-reference indicates that the book is designed as a practical manual. Rather than repeating the full text of these psalms, the reader is directed to where they appeared earlier in the text, demonstrating the systematic organization of Ma'avar Yabok as a reference guide for deathbed rituals.

[3] This superscription indicates performance instructions. While "lamnatzeaḥ" clearly refers to the director of music or chief musician, the meaning of "al-hagittit" remains debated among scholars. It might refer to a musical instrument, a particular melody, or a style of music from the Philistine city of Gath.

[4] The Korahites were a Levitical family who served as temple musicians and gatekeepers. Psalms 42-49, 84-85, and 87-88 are attributed to them. Their ancestral connection to the sanctuary makes their authorship of this psalm about temple longing particularly meaningful.

[5] The Hebrew uses two intense verbs ("nikhsefah" and "khaletah") that express extreme yearning and exhaustion from desire. This suggests the psalm may have originated from someone unable to access the temple, perhaps during exile or a pilgrimage journey.

mystical significance of the number 28 and its connection to divine power. | Cf. Exodus narrative — The phrases "the mighty hand and the outstretched arm" allude to biblical descriptions of God's power in delivering Israel from Egypt (Deuteronomy 4:34, 5:15, 7:19, 11:2, 26:8). These expressions of divine power are connected to the healing properties of the recommended psalms.

[i] This is a liturgical instruction indicating which psalms should be recited for a sick person. The notation uses Hebrew letters as numbers: ט״ו (15), כ׳ (20), כ״ב (22), כ״ג (23), כ״ד (24), כ״ה (25), ל׳ (30), מ׳ (40), מ״ג (43), נ״א (51), ס״ו (67).

[ii] This phrase means "you will find [them] above" and refers to the fact that these psalms were previously included in full text earlier in the book, so they are not repeated here.

יֵרָאֶה אֱלֹהִים בְּצִיּוֹן: יְיָ
אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת שִׁמְעָה תְפִלָּתִי
2585 הַאֲזִינָה אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה: מָגִנֵּנוּ
רְאֵה אֱלֹהִים וְהַבֵּט פְּנֵי מְשִׁיחֶךָ:
כִּי טוֹב־יוֹם בַּחֲצֵרֶיךָ מֵאָלֶף
בָּחַרְתִּי הִסְתּוֹפֵף בְּבֵית אֱלֹהַי
מִדּוּר בְּאָהֳלֵי־רֶשַׁע: כִּי שֶׁמֶשׁ וּמָגֵן
2590 יְיָ אֱלֹהִים חֵן וְכָבוֹד יִתֵּן יְיָ לֹא
יִמְנַע־טוֹב לַהֹלְכִים בְּתָמִים: יְיָ
צְבָאוֹת אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ: [i]

rain also covers it with blessings.[A] They go from strength to strength;[1] each one appears before God 2755R
in Zion. O LORD God of hosts, hear my prayer; give ear, O God of Jacob. Selah. Behold, O God our shield,[2] and look upon the face of Your anointed. For a day in Your courts is better than a thousand elsewhere.[3] I would rather be a doorkeeper in 2760R
the house of my God[B] than dwell in the tents of wickedness. For the LORD God is a sun and shield; the LORD will give grace and glory; no good thing will He withhold from those who walk uprightly.[4] O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in 2765R
You![5]

[A] Or: "the autumn rain also covers it with blessings" — The Hebrew 'moreh' specifically refers to the autumn or early rain in the agricultural cycle of ancient Israel, rather than just any early rain. This specific seasonal reference adds contextual meaning to the passage.

[B] Or: "I would rather stand at the threshold of the house of my God" — The Hebrew 'histofef' does not specifically mean to be a doorkeeper (an official position), but rather to stand at the threshold or to be on the edge of a sacred space. It conveys humility in just being present at the entrance rather than occupying an official role.

[1] This powerful metaphor describes the spiritual growth experienced during pilgrimage. Rather than becoming exhausted, the travelers gain increasing vigor as they approach their sacred destination. This verse has become an enduring image of spiritual progress in Jewish and Christian traditions.

[2] The psalm shifts here from describing pilgrims to a direct prayer, suggesting it may have been used liturgically at a point when pilgrims arrived at the temple. The image of God as a shield appears again in verse 11, creating a frame around this section of the psalm.

[3] This powerful comparative statement forms the emotional climax of the psalm. The intense valuation of sacred space—where a single day outweighs a thousand elsewhere—explains the psalmist's yearning expressed in earlier verses.

[4] The Hebrew "tamim" (translated as "uprightly") refers to completeness, integrity, and wholeness rather than moral perfection. The promise is that God's blessings flow to those whose lives are characterized by integrity and undivided devotion.

[5] The psalm begins and ends with statements of blessedness ("ashrei"), creating a frame that emphasizes that true happiness comes from proximity to God (dwelling in God's house) and reliance on God (trusting in God). This forms a thematic inclusion that unifies the entire psalm.

[i] Cf. Psalm 42 — Both psalms use intense physical yearning language ('longing,' 'thirsting,' 'fainting') to describe spiritual desire for God's presence. In Psalm 84, 'my soul longs, indeed faints' parallels Psalm 42's 'my soul thirsts for God.' Both express the psalmist's intense spiritual longing using bodily metaphors. | Cf. Psalm 27 — Psalm 84's celebration of those who 'dwell in Your house' echoes Psalm 27:4's 'One thing I have asked from the LORD... to dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life.' Both psalms present proximity to God's sanctuary as the ultimate blessing and privilege. | Cf. Exodus 23 — The phrase 'appears before God in Zion' in Psalm 84:7 likely alludes to the three annual pilgrimage festivals when Israelites were commanded to 'appear before the Lord.' The psalm thus celebrates these pilgrimage journeys to Jerusalem, depicting them as sources of spiritual strength and blessing. | Cf. Psalm 43 — Psalm 84's longing for God's courts echoes Psalm 43's plea to be led to God's 'holy hill' and 'tabernacles.' Both psalms portray God's sanctuary as the destination of spiritual journey and the place where true joy is found. | Cf. Song of Songs — The intense yearning expressed in Psalm 84 for God's dwelling places parallels the lover's desire in Song of Songs to know where the beloved rests and dwells. Both texts use the language of passionate desire to describe a spiritual relationship. In Jewish mystical tradition, both texts were interpreted as expressing the soul's longing for divine union.

צא קב קג קטו קיח[i] תמצא לעיל:[ii]

You will find[1] (the sections) 91, 102, 103, 115, 118[2] above.

(תהלים קכ) שִׁיר הַמַּעֲלוֹת[iii] אֶל־יְיָ בַּצָּרָתָה לִי קָרָאתִי וַיַּעֲנֵנִי: יְיָ הַצִּילָה נַפְשִׁי מִשְּׂפַת־שֶׁקֶר מִלָּשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה: מַה־יִּתֵּן לְךָ וּמַה־יֹּסִיף לָךְ לָשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה: חִצֵּי גִבּוֹר שְׁנוּנִים עִם גַּחֲלֵי רְתָמִים[iv]: אוֹיָה־לִי כִּי־גַרְתִּי מֶשֶׁךְ[v] שָׁכַנְתִּי עִם־אָהֳלֵי קֵדָר[vi]: רַבַּת שָׁכְנָה־לָּהּ נַפְשִׁי עִם שׂוֹנֵא שָׁלוֹם: אֲנִי־שָׁלוֹם וְכִי אֲדַבֵּר הֵמָּה לַמִּלְחָמָה:[vii]

(Psalm 120) A Song of Ascents. In my distress[A] I called to the LORD,[3] and He answered me. O LORD, deliver my soul from lying lips,[B4] from a deceitful tongue.[C] What will be given to you, and what more will be done to you, O deceitful tongue? Sharp arrows of a warrior, with burning coals of broom wood. Woe to me, for I have sojourned in Meshech, I have dwelled among the tents of Kedar. Too long has my soul dwelled with those who hate peace.[5] I am for peace, but when I speak, they are

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[A] Or: "In my straits" — The Hebrew term "tzarah" literally means "narrowness" or "constriction," which can be rendered as "straits" to preserve the spatial metaphor. This might better convey the feeling of confinement or limitation experienced during illness, which would be relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context.

[B] Or: "from the lip of falsehood, from the tongue of deception" — This more literal translation preserves the Hebrew construct form and might better capture the poetic parallelism of the original, though it sounds less natural in English.

[C] Or: "from the lip of falsehood, from the tongue of deception" — This more literal translation preserves the Hebrew construct form and might better capture the poetic parallelism of the original, though it sounds less natural in English.

[1] This is a navigational instruction common in rabbinic texts. The author is referring readers back to earlier sections of Ma'avar Yabok rather than repeating content.

[2] These numbers refer to specific paragraph or section numbers that appear earlier in the text. Such cross-references were common in works like Ma'avar Yabok to help readers navigate the complex structure without requiring repetition of material.

[3] This psalm opens with a cry of distress, fitting for its inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok's section on prayers for the sick and dying. The speaker's plea for divine deliverance from hostile surroundings would resonate with someone suffering illness or approaching death.

[4] The request for deliverance from falsehood may have been particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which emphasizes the importance of truth-telling with the sick and dying, rather than false reassurance.

[5] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this sentiment could be interpreted as the suffering person's

[i] These are section or paragraph numbers referring to earlier parts of the text. The instruction is directing the reader to refer back to these previously mentioned sections rather than repeating them here.

[ii] This phrase literally means "you will find above" and is a common navigational instruction in rabbinic texts, directing readers to look at earlier sections of the text.

[iii] "Song of Ascents" is the title given to fifteen psalms (Psalms 120-134) that were likely sung by pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem for the three annual festivals, or by Levites ascending the steps to the Temple.

[iv] "Coals of broom wood" (retem in Hebrew) refers to the desert broom plant, which produces particularly hot-burning and long-lasting coals, used metaphorically here to describe the lasting harm caused by deceitful speech.

[v] Meshech refers to a barbaric tribe descended from Japheth (Genesis 10:2), located far to the north of Israel, possibly in the region of modern Turkey or the Caucasus.

[vi] Kedar was a nomadic Arab tribe descended from Ishmael (Genesis 25:13), dwelling in the Arabian desert to the east of Israel. Meshech and Kedar represent distant, hostile peoples in opposite directions from Israel.

[vii] Cf. Psalm 118:5 — This allusion connects Psalm 120 to the theme of divine deliverance from constriction to expansiveness, which would be particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context of the soul's transition from the confinement of suffering to spiritual liberation. | Cf. Ma'avar

for war.

(תהלים קכא) שִׁיר לַמַּעֲלוֹת
אֶשָּׂא עֵינַי אֶל־הֶהָרִים[i] מֵאַיִן
יָבֹא עֶזְרִי[ii]: עֶזְרִי מֵעִם יְיָ עֹשֵׂה
שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ: אַל־יִתֵּן לַמּוֹט רַגְלֶךָ
אַל־יָנוּם שֹׁמְרֶךָ: הִנֵּה לֹא־יָנוּם
וְלֹא יִישָׁן שׁוֹמֵר יִשְׂרָאֵל: יְיָ
שֹׁמְרֶךָ יְיָ צִלְּךָ עַל־יַד יְמִינֶךָ[iii]:
יוֹמָם הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ לֹא־יַכֶּכָּה וְיָרֵחַ
בַּלָּיְלָה: יְיָ יִשְׁמָרְךָ מִכָּל־רָע יִשְׁמֹר
אֶת־נַפְשֶׁךָ[iv]: יְיָ יִשְׁמָר־צֵאתְךָ
וּבוֹאֶךָ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד־עוֹלָם: [v]

(Psalm 121) A Song of Ascents. I will lift up my eyes to the mountains;[1] from where will my help come? My help comes from the LORD, Maker of heaven and earth. He will not allow your foot to slip; your Guardian will not slumber. Behold, the Guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps. The LORD is your Guardian; the LORD is your shade upon your right hand.[2] The sun will not harm you by day, nor the moon by night.[3] The LORD will guard you from all evil; He will protect your soul. The LORD will guard your going out and your coming in[4] from now and forevermore. 2780R 2785R 2790R

קל קמ קמא קמב קמג קמח קמט

The psalms numbered 130, 140, 141, 142, 143, 148,

weariness with the conflict between life and death, or the soul's desire to depart from a body and world characterized by strife.

[1]This opening line establishes a visual metaphor of looking upward, which in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed rituals takes on additional significance as the upward journey of the departing soul.

[2]The right side is associated with mercy and kindness in kabbalistic tradition, while the left is associated with judgment. God providing shade specifically 'upon your right hand' suggests divine mercy tempering the intensity of spiritual light during the soul's transition.

[3]In mystical interpretation, the sun and moon represent different types of spiritual influences or judgments. This verse promises protection from all forms of harmful spiritual forces, particularly relevant during the vulnerable time of death when the soul faces various spiritual trials.

[4]While this typically refers to daily activities in life, in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's death rituals, this phrase takes on deeper significance as referring to the soul's exit from the body ('going out') and entrance into the afterlife ('coming in').

Yabok — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok suggests it was considered particularly appropriate for those experiencing serious illness or approaching death, perhaps because it expresses both distress in hostile surroundings and confidence in divine response.

[i]The Hebrew phrase can be read as both a statement ('I lift my eyes to the mountains') and as a question ('Shall I lift my eyes to the mountains?'). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this ambiguity takes on spiritual significance, suggesting the soul's questioning of where to turn at the moment of transition.

[ii]The Hebrew 'me'ayin' (from where) contains the word 'ayin' (nothingness), creating a mystical reading: 'my help comes from divine nothingness,' referring to God's transcendence beyond all definition.

[iii]The image of God as 'shade' (tzel) is significant in kabbalistic thought, representing divine protection that shields but doesn't obstruct spiritual light completely. In the context of death rituals in Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the perfect balance of divine presence during the soul's transition.

[iv]The Hebrew 'nafshecha' (your soul) specifically refers to the nefesh level of the soul in kabbalistic thought. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this indicates divine protection specifically for the aspect of soul most connected to the body during the separation process of death.

[v]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — Psalm 121 appears in Ma'avar Yabok as a protective prayer to be recited three times by those attending a sick person, reflecting the belief that this psalm has special power to invoke divine protection during illness and at the time of death. | Cf. Zohar — The psalm's emphasis on divine guardianship connects to the Zoharic concept that while the soul experiences suffering during its departure from the body, it encounters divine mercy after separation is complete. | Cf. Traditional Jewish liturgy — This psalm is traditionally recited as part of the bedtime Shema ritual, creating a parallel between sleep and death, with both requiring divine protection.

קנ תמצא לעיל:[i]

149, and 150 can be found above.

ואלה הם קי״ב פסוקי תורה
נביאים וכתובי׳[ii] יחד כלם
טובים לישא אותם על שפתיו
האיש הישראלי או העומדי׳
עליו מדי עברו את מעבר י״בק
מתחתית לעילית[iii] ומספר
מפקד הפסוקי׳ מכוון ליחוד
ג׳ שמות שהם הוי״ה אהי״ה
אדנו״ת[iv] מספרם יחד קי״ב
וימצא בין פסוקי תורה לנביאים
וכן לכתובים ב׳ או ג׳ מזמורים
מהנרשמים ויכון האומר כי
נצוץ נשמת החולה שכלול׳
בנשמתו[v] על דרך כל ישראל
ערבין זה לזה בכחי נותן כח
ואון לו ופיו כפיו ודבורו
כדבור המוטל על ערש דוי וכמו
שמוסיף שפע רצון על נשמת
האיש הלזה כן יתוסף לו רבו

And these are the 112 verses[1] from Torah, Prophets, and Writings together—all of them beneficial to carry on one's lips, whether the Israelite person himself or those attending him as he crosses over the Ford of Jabbok from below to above.[A] The count of these verses corresponds to the unification of three Divine Names: YHVH, Ehyeh, and Adonut,[2] which together equal 112. Between the verses from Torah to Prophets, and likewise to Writings, two or three psalms from those indicated should be recited. The one who recites should have in mind that the spark of the sick person's soul is included within his own soul,[B] in the manner that "all Israel are guarantors for one another." Through my strength, I give strength and vigor to him, and my mouth is like his mouth, and my speech like the speech of one lying on a sickbed. And just as one adds a flow of divine favor to the soul of this person, so shall increase be added to him in abundance, life, grace,

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[A] Or: "during his passage through the Ford of Jabbok from the lower realm to the higher realm" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the kabbalistic concept of spiritual ascent through different realms or worlds, which is implied in the Hebrew terms 'tachtit' (lower) and 'ilit' (higher).

[B] Or: "the divine spark of the sick person's soul is encompassed within his own soul" — This alternative emphasizes the divine nature of the soul spark, which is implied in kabbalistic understanding of 'nitzotz neshama' (soul spark) as a fragment of divinity.

[1] The text refers to a specific collection of biblical verses compiled in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation at the deathbed. The number 112 is significant because it equals the numerical value of three divine names mentioned in the text.

[2] In Jewish mysticism, reciting verses corresponding to divine names creates a spiritual unification (yichud) that helps elevate the soul. These specific names represent different aspects of God's nature and relationship with humanity.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section — This brief reference directs the reader to psalms that have already been included earlier in the text. This type of cross-reference was a common feature in early printed books, allowing the author to avoid repetition while ensuring readers could locate important content. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these psalms form part of the liturgical sequences designed to be recited for or by the sick and dying.

[ii] The number 112 (קי״ב) is significant as it equals the combined numerical value of three divine names mentioned later in the text. This gematria (Hebrew numerology) creates a mystical correspondence between the number of verses and divine unity.

[iii] This phrase has dual meaning: literally referring to Jacob's biblical crossing of the Jabbok River, and metaphorically representing the soul's transition from the physical world ('below') to spiritual realms ('above') at death.

[iv] These three divine names represent different aspects of God in Kabbalah: YHVH (the Tetragrammaton) represents God's eternal unchanging nature, Ehyeh ('I will be') represents God's self-revelation to Moses at the burning bush, and Adonut represents God's sovereignty. Their numerical values are: YHVH (26) + Ehyeh (21) + Adonut (65) = 112.

[v] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that all Jewish souls are interconnected, with each containing sparks of the others. This mystical interconnection enables one person to effectively pray or recite verses on behalf of another.

וחיי וחינא וחסדא וכל המוסיף מוסיפין לו:[i] [ii]

and kindness[A]—for whoever adds, addition is made for him.[1]

פתיחה לפסוקים[iii] [iv]

Introduction to the Verses[2] 2815R

2640 הַאֲזִינוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וַאֲדַבֵּרָה וְתִשְׁמַע הָאָרֶץ אִמְרֵי פִי: יַעֲרֹף כַּמָּטָר

Listen, O heavens,[3] and I will speak; and let the earth hear the words of my mouth. My teaching

[A] Or: "And just as he channels a flow of divine will to the soul of this person, so shall he receive increase in abundance, vitality, grace, and loving-kindness" — This alternative more directly captures the reciprocal spiritual dynamic described, where the person praying actively channels divine energy (shefa ratzon) rather than merely adding to it, and receives specific spiritual qualities in return.

[1] This is a principle of reciprocal spiritual benefit, suggesting that those who help elevate the souls of others receive divine blessing in return. It encourages participation in the deathbed ritual as spiritually beneficial for both the dying and those attending them.

[2] This section serves as a formal opening to the recitation of 112 biblical verses that Ma'avar Yabok prescribes for those approaching death. These introductory verses establish a solemn, sacred atmosphere through invocations of divine presence and protection.

[3] This passage combines verses from multiple biblical sources to create a comprehensive prayer of protection. The opening verses from Deuteronomy 32 invoke divine attention, followed by verses from various Psalms that emphasize divine protection, trust, and deliverance.

[i] This is a play on a rabbinic principle similar to 'measure for measure' (midah k'neged midah), suggesting that divine reward corresponds to human action. Here it specifically means that by adding benefit to another's soul, one receives spiritual addition to one's own soul.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok (Title of the book) — The mention of 'crossing the Ford of Jabbok' (מעבר יבק) directly references the book's title and central metaphor. Just as Jacob crossed the Jabbok before his transformative encounter, the soul crosses from the physical world to the spiritual realm at death. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Shevuot 39a — The phrase 'all Israel are guarantors for one another' is a direct quotation from the Talmud, used here to explain the mystical connection between souls that allows one person to recite verses on behalf of another. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 104a — The final phrase 'whoever adds, addition is made for him' echoes this Talmudic principle, suggesting that the merit earned by helping a dying person is reciprocated with divine blessing. | Cf. Genesis 32:22-32 — The phrase 'crossing over the Ford of Jabbok from below to above' alludes to Jacob's biblical crossing but reinterprets it kabbalistically as the soul's ascent from the lower to higher spiritual worlds.

[iii] This heading marks the beginning of an introductory prayer sequence before the recitation of the 112 biblical verses that follow. This structure is typical of Ma'avar Yabok's organized approach to deathbed liturgy.

[iv] Cf. Deuteronomy 32:1 — This verse calls heaven and earth to witness, establishing a cosmic framework for what follows. In the context of deathbed rituals, it summons the entirety of creation to attend to the solemnity of the moment when a soul prepares to depart. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:2 — This verse uses natural metaphors of rain and dew to express how divine teaching penetrates and nourishes. In Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests how the biblical verses that follow should gently refresh and sustain the soul of the dying person. | Cf. Psalm 46:8, 12 — These verses provide assurance of divine protection at a time of vulnerability. The repetition of 'the LORD of hosts is with us' creates a protective spiritual environment around the dying person. | Cf. Psalm 20:10 — This verse petitions God to hear and respond, particularly relevant when praying for someone transitioning between worlds, when divine attention is especially sought. | Cf. Psalm 32:7 — This verse portrays God as both shelter and source of joy even amid distress, offering comfort to the dying person that they are encompassed by divine protection. | Cf. Isaiah 26:4 — This verse encourages absolute trust in God's eternal nature, providing a theological foundation for surrendering one's soul to divine care at death. | Cf. Psalm 29:11 — This verse invokes divine strength and peace at a time when physical strength is failing, reassuring that God's peace transcends physical decline. | Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel — This reference to four archangels (Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Noriel) and the Divine Presence above creates a visualization of divine protection encompassing the dying person from all directions, creating a safe spiritual passage.

לִקְחִי תִּזַּל כַּטַּל אִמְרָתִי כִּשְׂעִירִם
עָלֵי דֶשֶׁא וְכִרְבִיבִים עָלֵי עֵשֶׂב:
יְיָ צְבָאוֹת עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי
2645 יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה: יְיָ צְבָאוֹת אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם
בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ
יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ: אַתָּה סֵתֶר לִי
מִצַּר תִּצְּרֵנִי רָנֵי פַלֵּט תְּסוֹבְבֵנִי
סֶלָה: בְּטְחוּ בַיְיָ עֲדֵי עַד כִּי בְיָהּ
2650 יְיָ צוּר עוֹלָמִים: יְיָ עֹז לְעַמּוֹ יִתֵּן
יְיָ יְבָרֵךְ אֶת עַמּוֹ בַשָּׁלוֹם: מִימִינוֹ
מִיכָאֵל מִשְּׂמֹאלוֹ גַּבְרִיאֵל מִלְּפָנָיו
רְפָאֵל מֵאֲחוֹרָיו נוֹרִיאֵל וְעַל
ראשו שְׁכִינַת אֵל: [i]

shall drop as the rain, my speech shall distill as the dew, as the gentle rain upon the tender grass, and as the showers upon the herb. The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge. Selah. O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in You. Save, O LORD; may the King answer us on the day we call. You are my hiding place; You preserve me from trouble; You surround me with songs of deliverance.[1] Selah. Trust in the LORD forever, for in YAH, the LORD, is an everlasting rock.[2] The LORD will give strength to His people; the LORD will bless His people with peace. Michael is at his right, Gabriel at his left, Raphael before him, Noriel behind him, and above his head is the Divine Presence.[3]

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עיין בזהר פרשת ויקהל טעם לפסוק יערוף כמטר וגו׳: [ii]

See the Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel, for the reason behind the verse "May my teaching drop like rain, etc."

אם ירצה יתחיל מזמור כ״ג או

If desired, one may begin with Psalm 23 or 25 or 30

2835R

[1]The Hebrew term 'ranei palet' literally means 'songs of deliverance' or 'joyful cries of escape,' suggesting that divine protection includes not only safety but also jubilation at being rescued.

[2]In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which deals with death and transition, the image of God as an 'everlasting rock' (tzur olamim) takes on special significance, contrasting divine permanence with human mortality.

[3]The Hebrew text concludes with a non-biblical formula invoking angelic protection. This protective arrangement—with four archangels surrounding the person and the Divine Presence above—creates a spiritual shield around the ill or dying person from all directions. This formula appears frequently in Jewish protective prayers and amulets.

[i]Cf. Deuteronomy 32:1-2 — The opening verses are a direct quote from the beginning of Moses' song in Deuteronomy 32. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses serve to invoke divine attention before reciting prayers for the sick or dying. | Cf. Psalm 46:8 — This verse from Psalms emphasizes divine protection. In the context of prayers for the sick, it reassures that God's protective presence remains with the afflicted person. | Cf. Psalm 84:13 — This verse affirms the blessedness of trusting in God even during illness or approaching death, reinforcing the spiritual focus of Ma'avar Yabok's approach to end-of-life care. | Cf. Psalm 20:10 — This verse is a plea for divine salvation, particularly appropriate in the context of prayers for the critically ill. | Cf. Psalm 32:7 — This verse portrays God as a protective hiding place during trouble, offering comfort to those experiencing illness or approaching death. | Cf. Isaiah 26:4 — This verse encourages perpetual trust in God as an everlasting foundation, particularly relevant for those facing mortality. | Cf. Psalm 29:11 — This verse promises divine strength and peace, comforting concepts for both the sick person and those caring for them. | Cf. Talmudic and Kabbalistic tradition — The concluding formula about the four archangels surrounding a person with the Divine Presence above appears frequently in Jewish protective prayers. In Ma'avar Yabok, this formula creates a spiritual shield around the ill or dying person, invoking angelic protection from all directions.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The Zohar typically interprets this verse mystically, explaining how divine teachings flow downward like rain from higher spiritual realms to nourish the lower worlds, just as rain descends from heaven to nourish the earth. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:2 — The abbreviated phrase 'יערוף כמטר וגו' (may my teaching drop like rain, etc.) refers to the full verse 'May my teaching drop like rain, my speech distill as dew, like gentle rain on tender grass, and like showers on the herb.' This is a common liturgical device in Ma'avar Yabok, where the opening of a verse is cited with the expectation that the reader would mentally complete it.

כ״ה או ל׳ ל״ב[i] או שאר מזמורים מהמסומנים:[ii] or 32[1] or other psalms from those marked.[2]

כאן מתחילים היב״ק פסוקים[iii][iv] Here begin the YaBOK verses[3]

הראשונים הם כ״א במספר אך טוב לישראל[v][vi] These are the first, 21 in number,[4] [corresponding to] "But good for Israel"[5]

[1]These are specific psalms that have been identified as particularly appropriate for recitation at the bedside of someone who is ill or dying. Psalm 23 is the well-known 'The LORD is my shepherd' psalm, often recited for comfort in difficult times. Psalm 25 is a prayer for divine guidance and forgiveness. Psalm 30 is a song of thanksgiving for recovery from grave illness. Psalm 32 expresses the joy of receiving divine forgiveness.

[2]The text is referring to a previously provided list of recommended psalms that are suitable for recitation at the bedside of the ill or dying. This instruction allows flexibility in choosing which psalms to recite, while still directing the reader to select from those that have been specifically identified as appropriate for this ritual context.

[3]This simple heading has profound significance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok. It marks the beginning of 112 carefully selected biblical verses that were to be recited for someone approaching death. The numerical value of YaBOK (יב״ק) equals 112, and these verses are divided into groups corresponding to divine names (21 for Ehyeh, 26 for YHVH, and 65 for Adnut), creating a comprehensive spiritual framework for the soul's transition.

[4]The text is introducing the first group of biblical verses in a structured collection of 112 verses that will be recited for someone who is dying. These 21 verses correspond to the divine name אהי״ה (Ehyeh), which has the numerical value of 21.

[5]The phrase 'אך טוב לישראל' (But good for Israel) serves as a thematic title for this first set of verses

[i]The text lists specific psalm numbers that are recommended for recitation: Psalm 23 ('The LORD is my shepherd'), Psalm 25 ('To You, O LORD, I lift up my soul'), Psalm 30 ('I will extol You, O LORD'), and Psalm 32 ('Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven'). These psalms were selected for their themes of divine protection, guidance, healing, and forgiveness, making them especially appropriate for deathbed contexts.

[ii]This phrase refers to psalms that have been previously marked or designated in the text as suitable for recitation at the bedside of the ill or dying. Ma'avar Yabok includes extensive lists of appropriate psalms and prayers organized for specific ritual contexts.

[iii]This heading marks the beginning of the central 112 biblical verses that are organized into groups corresponding to divine names. The acronym YaBOK (יב״ק) serves both as a reference to the book's title (Crossing of the Jabbok) and as a mnemonic for the verses' spiritual purpose in facilitating the soul's transition.

[iv]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The acronym YaBOK (יב״ק) refers to both the title of the book (Ma'avar Yabok/Crossing of the Yabok) and to the specific 112 verses that follow, which are divided into groups corresponding to divine names. These verses were meant to be recited for someone transitioning from life to death, facilitating the soul's peaceful journey. | Cf. Genesis 32:22-32 — The YaBOK verses allude to Jacob's transformative crossing of the Jabbok River, which serves as the central metaphor for the entire book—representing the soul's transition from this world to the next.

[v]This line introduces the first set of 21 biblical verses in a collection of 112 verses arranged according to divine names. The phrase 'אך טוב לישראל' (But good for Israel) serves both as a reference to Psalm 73:1 and as a thematic title for this set of verses. The number 21 corresponds to the numerical value of the divine name אהי״ה (Ehyeh).

[vi]Cf. Psalm 73:1 — The text is indicating that the 21 verses that follow correspond to the divine name אהי״ה (Ehyeh), which has the numerical value of 21. The phrase 'But good for Israel' serves as both a reference to Psalm 73 and as a thematic introduction to these verses, which are intended to bring divine goodness and protection to the sick or dying person. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The text indicates that these are the first 21 verses of a collection of 112 biblical verses organized according to divine names (21 for אהי״ה, 26 for יהו״ה, and 65 for אדנו״ת). The numerical value of YaBOK (יב״ק) equals 112, which is the total number of verses compiled in this section to aid the soul's transition at death.

(תורה) לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְיָ [i] ישר
הפוך ישר: לִפּוּרְקָנָךְ סְבָרִית
יְיָ ישר הפוך ישר: וְיַעֲקֹב הָלַךְ
לְדַרְכּוֹ וַיִּפְגְּעוּ בוֹ מַלְאֲכֵי אֱלֹהִים:
וַיֹּאמֶר יַעֲקֹב כַּאֲשֶׁר רָאָם מַחֲנֵה
אֱלֹהִים זֶה וַיִּקְרָא שֵׁם הַמָּקוֹם
הַהוּא מַחֲנָיִם: [iii] וְאַתָּה תָּבוֹא אֶל
אֲבֹתֶיךָ בְּשָׁלוֹם תִּקָּבֵר בְּשֵׂיבָה
טוֹבָה: וַיִּסַּע מַלְאַךְ הָאֱלֹהִים
הַהֹלֵךְ לִפְנֵי מַחֲנֵה יִשְׂרָאֵל וַיֵּלֶךְ
מֵאַחֲרֵיהֶם וַיִּסַּע עַמּוּד הֶעָנָן
מִפְּנֵיהֶם וַיַּעֲמֹד מֵאַחֲרֵיהֶם: וַיָּבֹא
בֵּין מַחֲנֵה מִצְרַיִם וּבֵין מַחֲנֵה
יִשְׂרָאֵל וַיְהִי הֶעָנָן וְהַחֹשֶׁךְ וַיָּאֶר
אֶת הַלָּיְלָה וְלֹא קָרַב זֶה אֶל זֶה
כָּל הַלָּיְלָה: וַיֵּט מֹשֶׁה אֶת יָדוֹ עַל
הַיָּם וַיּוֹלֶךְ יְיָ אֶת הַיָּם בְּרוּחַ קָדִים
עַזָּה כָּל הַלַּיְלָה וַיָּשֶׂם אֶת הַיָּם
לֶחָרָבָה וַיִּבָּקְעוּ הַמָּיִם: [v] [iv]

For Your salvation I wait, O LORD [forward, backward, forward]: For Your redemption I hope, O LORD [forward, backward, forward]:[A] And Jacob went on his way, and angels of God encountered him. And Jacob said when he saw them, "This is God's camp,"[B] [1] and he called the name of that place Mahanaim.[C] And you shall go to your fathers in peace; you shall be buried in a good old age. And the angel of God, who went before the camp of Israel, moved and went behind them; and the pillar of cloud moved from before them and stood behind them. And it came between the camp of Egypt and the camp of Israel; and there was the cloud and the darkness, yet it gave light by night; and the one came not near the other all the night. And Moses stretched out his hand over the sea; and the LORD caused the sea to go back by a strong east wind all the night, and made the sea dry land, and the waters were divided.[2]

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[A] Or: "For Your salvation I wait, O LORD [to be recited forward, then backward, then forward again]: For Your redemption I hope, O LORD [to be recited forward, then backward, then forward again]" — The Hebrew 'ישר הפוך ישר' appears to be instructions for how to recite the verse rather than part of the verse itself. This alternative makes the instructional nature of these words clearer to a modern reader.

[B] Or: "a camp of God" — The Hebrew lacks the definite article, so 'a camp of God' might be more literal, though 'God's camp' flows better in English.

[C] Or: "and he called the name of that place Mahanaim [Two Camps]" — Adding the translation of 'Mahanaim' as 'Two Camps' would help readers understand the significance of the name, which relates to the encounter with the divine host joining the human company.

and is the opening of Psalm 73:1. This collection of verses is designed to bring divine protection and aid to the dying person's soul as it transitions from this world.

[1] The recognition of divine presence at critical transition points is a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok. Just as Jacob recognized God's presence at Mahanaim during his journey, those attending the dying are encouraged to recognize the sacred nature of the death transition.

[2] These verses are specifically selected for their imagery of divine protection during transitions.

[i] This verse comes from Genesis 49:18, part of Jacob's deathbed blessings to his sons. Its use here creates a powerful connection between Jacob's approaching death and the situation of the dying person for whom these verses are being recited.

[ii] These words are not part of the biblical verse but rather instructions for how to recite the verse: first forward (in normal order), then backward (in reverse order), then forward again. This technique of repetition with variation was considered to have special spiritual power.

[iii] The name 'Mahanaim' means 'Two Camps' in Hebrew, referring to Jacob's camp meeting the divine camp (the angels). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this name takes on special significance as it symbolizes the meeting point between the earthly and heavenly realms during the soul's transition.

[iv] The parting of the waters serves as a powerful metaphor for the soul's transition at death—just as the Israelites passed through the divided sea from one state of existence to another, so does the soul pass from life to the afterlife.

[v] Cf. Genesis 32:1-2 — The reference to Jacob's encounter with angels at Mahanaim is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as the book's title directly references Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River. Here it establishes a parallel between Jacob's journey with divine protection and the soul's journey in transition from life to death. | Cf. Genesis 15:15 — The verse 'And you shall go to your fathers in peace; you shall be buried in a good old age' was originally God's

(נביאים) כִּי יְיָ שֹׁפְטֵנוּ יְיָ מְחֹקְקֵנוּ
יְיָ מַלְכֵּנוּ הוּא יוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ: פִּתְחוּ
שְׁעָרִים[i] וְיָבֹא גוֹי צַדִּיק שֹׁמֵר
אֱמֻנִים: וְיָשַׁב עַמִּי בִּנְוֵה שָׁלוֹם
וּבְמִשְׁכְּנוֹת מִבְטָחִים וּבְמְנוּחֹת
שַׁאֲנַנוֹת:[ii] וְקוֵי יְיָ יַחֲלִיפוּ כֹחַ
יַעֲלוּ אֵבֶר כַּנְּשָׁרִים[iii] יָרוּצוּ וְלֹא
יִיגָעוּ יֵלְכוּ וְלֹא יִיעָפוּ: כִּי תַעֲבֹר
בַּמַּיִם אִתְּךָ וּבַנְּהָרוֹת לֹא
יִשְׁטְפוּךָ כִּי תֵלֵךְ בְּמוֹ אֵשׁ לֹא
תִכָּוֶה וְלֶהָבָה לֹא תִבְעַר בָּךְ: אָנֹכִי
אָנֹכִי הוּא[iv] מֹחֶה פְּשָׁעֶיךָ לְמַעֲנִי
וְחַטֹּאתֶיךָ לֹא אֶזְכֹּר: הָזְכִּירֵנִי נָבוֹא
יָחַד מִשְׁפָּט הַצְדֶּק אֲמָרֶיךָ
כִּי גֶאְלְתִּיךָ:[v]

For the LORD is our judge, the LORD is our lawgiver, the LORD is our king; He will save us.[1] Open 2860R
the gates, that a righteous nation that keeps faith may enter. My people shall dwell in peaceful habitations, in secure dwellings, and in quiet resting places. But those who wait upon the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like ea- 2865R
gles,[2] they shall run and not grow weary, they shall walk and not faint. When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; and through the rivers, they shall not overflow you. When you walk through fire, you shall not be burned, nor shall the flame scorch 2870R
you. I, even I, am He who blots out your transgressions for My own sake; and your sins I will not remember. I have blotted out, like a thick cloud, your

The parting of the Red Sea serves as a powerful metaphor for the soul's passage from life to death—a journey through a seemingly impassable barrier that becomes possible through divine intervention.

[1]The Hebrew text establishes a theological framework where the same God who judges and legislates also provides salvation, offering reassurance to the dying person that divine judgment is tempered with mercy.

[2]This familiar image of strength renewal and soaring is particularly appropriate in death contexts, representing the soul's liberation from physical constraints and its ability to ascend to spiritual realms.

promise to Abraham. In this context, it's repurposed as a comforting assurance for the dying person, suggesting that death can be peaceful and a natural completion of life. | Cf. Exodus 14:19-21 — The verses describing the angel of God and the pillar of cloud protecting Israel, followed by Moses parting the Red Sea, create a powerful metaphor for divine protection during transitions. Just as God protected Israel during their transition from Egypt to freedom, these verses suggest God will protect the soul during its transition from life to death. | Cf. Genesis 49:18 — The opening line 'For Your salvation I wait, O LORD' comes from Jacob's deathbed blessings to his sons, making it especially appropriate in a deathbed context. It expresses hope and trust in divine salvation even at the moment of death.

[i]The phrase 'open the gates' takes on particular significance in the context of death rituals, where it can be understood as referring to the gates of the heavenly realm opening to receive the soul of the departed.

[ii]The text employs three distinct terms for peaceful dwelling places, potentially corresponding to the three levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, and neshamah) in kabbalistic thought, each finding its appropriate resting place in the afterlife.

[iii]The Hebrew phrase 'ya'alu ever' (they shall mount up with wings) uses imagery of ascent that resonates with the soul's upward journey after death. The eagle metaphor suggests both power and transcendence.

[iv]The doubling of 'anochi' (I) creates emphasis and suggests absolute divine authority in the act of forgiveness, particularly meaningful in the context of deathbed confessions.

[v]Cf. Isaiah 33:22 — This verse establishes God as the ultimate authority in three roles: judge, lawgiver, and king. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this serves to comfort the dying by reminding them that the same God who judges also saves, offering reassurance that divine judgment is tempered with mercy. | Cf. Isaiah 26:2 — This verse envisions gates opening for the righteous, which in the context of a deathbed ritual represents the soul's passage to the afterlife. The emphasis on faithfulness suggests that proper spiritual preparation ensures smooth transition after death. | Cf. Isaiah 32:18 — This verse promises peaceful dwellings and secure rest, serving as a reassurance that the soul of the departed will find tranquility after death. The three terms for restful places (peaceful habitations, secure dwellings, quiet resting places) may correspond to different levels of the soul's repose in the afterlife. | Cf. Isaiah 40:31 — This familiar verse

transgressions, and like a cloud, your sins. Return to Me, for I have redeemed you.[1] 2875R

(כתובים) עָנָה דוֹדִי וְאָמַר לִי
קוּמִי לָךְ רַעְיָתִי יָפָתִי וּלְכִי לָךְ:
2700 אִתִּי מִלְּבָנוֹן כַּלָּה[i] אִתִּי מִלְּבָנוֹן
תָּבוֹאִי תָּשׁוּרִי מֵרֹאשׁ אֲמָנָה מֵרֹאשׁ
שְׂנִיר וְחֶרְמוֹן מִמְּעֹנוֹת אֲרָיוֹת
מֵהַרְרֵי נְמֵרִים:[ii] שְׁמֹאלוֹ תַּחַת
לְרֹאשִׁי וִימִינוֹ תְּחַבְּקָנִי:[iii] עוּרִי
2705 צָפוֹן וּבוֹאִי תֵימָן הָפִיחִי גַּנִּי
יִזְּלוּ בְשָׂמָיו[iv] יָבֹא דוֹדִי לְגַנּוֹ

My beloved answered and said to me,[2] "Arise, my love, my beautiful one, and come away.[3] With me from Lebanon, my bride, with me from Lebanon you shall come; gaze from the summit of Amana, from the peak of Senir and Hermon, from the dens of 2880R lions, from the mountains of leopards.[A] His left hand is under my head, and his right hand embraces me. Awake, O north wind, and come, O south wind! Blow upon my garden, let its spices flow. Let my beloved

[A] Or: "With me from Lebanon, O bride, with me from Lebanon you shall journey; you shall look down from the peak of Amana, from the summit of Senir and Hermon, from the lairs of lions, from the mountains of leopards." — This alternate translation varies some of the vocabulary choices for more precise contextual meaning, particularly using 'journey' instead of 'come' and 'lairs' instead of 'dens' for the lion habitations. It also reverses 'summit' and 'peak' to better reflect the Hebrew terms.

[1] The Hebrew term 'ge'alticha' (I have redeemed you) carries connotations of both redemption and kinship obligation, suggesting that God acts as a redeemer not only out of mercy but also out of covenantal responsibility.

[2] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the 'beloved' (dodi) is understood as God, and this passage represents the divine call to the soul at the moment of death. What follows is God's invitation to the soul to depart from the body and ascend to the spiritual realms.

[3] This tender call from the beloved (God) to the soul takes on profound significance in the context of deathbed rituals. It reframes death not as abandonment but as a loving invitation from God to the soul to depart from its earthly vessel and journey to spiritual realms.

about renewed strength and soaring like eagles is reimagined in the context of death as describing the soul's liberation from the constraints of the physical body, able to ascend freely without the weariness that characterized earthly existence. | Cf. Isaiah 43:2 — The imagery of safely passing through waters and fire represents the soul's journey through the transitional states after death. In kabbalistic thought, these elements often symbolize the purifying processes the soul undergoes, with divine protection ensuring safe passage. | Cf. Isaiah 43:25 — This verse about God blotting out transgressions relates directly to the deathbed confession (vidui) emphasized throughout Ma'avar Yabok. The repeated 'I' (anochi anochi) emphasizes that only God has the ultimate power to forgive sins. | Cf. Isaiah 44:22 — The image of sins being blotted out like clouds completes the forgiveness theme, with the call to return (shuvah) connecting to the concept of teshuvah (repentance) that Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes as essential preparation for death.

[i] The repetition of 'with me from Lebanon' emphasizes the divine call to the soul. In the mystical context of Ma'avar Yabok, Lebanon (which means 'white' in Hebrew) represents the realm of purification that the soul must pass through on its journey after death.

[ii] The 'dens of lions' and 'mountains of leopards' are traditionally interpreted in Jewish mysticism as representing spiritual dangers or accusers that the soul encounters after death. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses take on special significance as they describe the soul's journey from places of spiritual danger to divine embrace.

[iii] In Kabbalistic imagery, God's left hand represents the attribute of judgment (gevurah) while His right hand represents loving-kindness (chesed). This verse suggests that the soul is embraced by both divine justice and mercy, with mercy (the right hand) ultimately embracing and predominating.

[iv] The north and south winds in Kabbalistic interpretation represent different spiritual forces. The north wind is associated with severity and judgment, while the south wind represents kindness and mercy. The call for both winds suggests a balanced spiritual awakening that will allow the soul's inherent qualities (the garden's spices) to be fully expressed.

וְיֹאכַל פְּרִי מִגְדָּיו: וַאֲנִי בְּרֹב חַסְדְּךָ אָבֹא בֵּיתֶךָ אֶשְׁתַּחֲוֶה הֵיכַל קָדְשְׁךָ בְּיִרְאָתֶךָ: נַצְּלֵנִי מֵאֹיְבַי עָז וּמִשֹּׂנְאַי כִּי אָמְצוּ מִמֶּנִּי: אֲנִי שָׁכַבְתִּי וָאִישָׁנָה הֱקִיצוֹתִי כִּי יְיָ יִסְמְכֵנִי: [i]

come to his garden and eat its choice fruits."[A] And I, through Your abundant loving-kindness, will enter Your house; I will bow down toward Your holy temple in reverence of You. Deliver me from my strong enemy, and from those who hate me, for they are too mighty for me. I lay down and slept; I awoke, for the LORD sustains me."[1] 2885R 2890R

אלה הם כ״א פסוקים כמספר אהי״ה: [ii]

These are 21 verses corresponding to the numerical value of the divine name Ehyeh.

יאמר[iii] מזמור מ״ב או מ״ג

He shall recite[2] Psalm 42 or 43 or 51,[3] or he shall

[A] Or: "Awaken, O north wind, and come, O south wind! Breathe upon my garden, that its fragrances may flow forth. May my beloved enter his garden and eat its precious fruits." — This alternative more precisely captures the sensual imagery of the Hebrew with 'breathe upon' rather than 'blow upon', 'fragrances' rather than 'spices', and 'precious fruits' rather than 'choice fruits'. The phrase 'flow forth' better conveys the imagery of fragrance dispersal than simply 'flow'.

[1] This final verse from Psalm 3 is particularly meaningful in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed rituals, as it reframes death as a form of sleep from which one will awaken through divine support. The verse offers comfort by suggesting that death is not final extinction but a transition to be followed by awakening through God's sustaining power.

[2] The Hebrew term 'יאמר' indicates a formal recitation in a liturgical context, not merely casual speaking. This is a directive for the person leading prayers for the sick or dying person.

[3] These specific psalms are recommended because of their thematic relevance to situations of illness

[i] Cf. Song of Songs — This passage quotes directly from Song of Songs, a text traditionally read as an allegory for the love between God and Israel. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses from Song of Songs represent the divine beloved (God) calling to the soul to arise and journey from this world to the next. The garden imagery represents the Garden of Eden where the soul will find rest after death. | Cf. Psalm 5:7-8 — The verse 'And I, through Your abundant loving-kindness, will enter Your house...' is a direct quote from Psalm 5:7-8. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm verse is repurposed as a prayer for the soul to be admitted to God's heavenly dwelling after death through divine mercy rather than personal merit. | Cf. Psalm 18:17 — The verse 'Deliver me from my strong enemy, and from those who hate me, for they are too mighty for me' is from Psalm 18:17. In the deathbed context of Ma'avar Yabok, these enemies can be understood as the Angel of Death or other spiritual accusers that might impede the soul's peaceful transition. | Cf. Psalm 3:5 — The final verse 'I lay down and slept; I awoke, for the LORD sustains me' comes from Psalm 3:5. In the Ma'avar Yabok context, this verse takes on profound significance as it reframes death as a form of sleep from which the soul will awaken through divine support, metaphorically pointing to the hope of resurrection. | Cf. Zohar — The Zohar interprets the Song of Songs as describing the soul's ascent through various spiritual levels. The mountains mentioned (Lebanon, Amana, Senir, Hermon) are understood as spiritual obstacles the soul must overcome in its journey. The 'dens of lions' and 'mountains of leopards' represent dangerous spiritual forces or accusers that the soul must navigate past.

[ii] Cf. Divine name Ehyeh (אהי״ה) — The divine name Ehyeh (אהי״ה) comes from God's self-revelation to Moses at the burning bush where God says 'Ehyeh asher Ehyeh' (I am who I am). In Kabbalah, this name has the numerical value of 21 (א=1, ה=5, י=10, ה=5) and is associated with the divine attribute of Keter (Crown), the highest sefirah. The 21 verses that follow are meant to be recited at the deathbed and are grouped according to divine names to facilitate the soul's transition. | Cf. YaBOK verses — This is part of a larger collection of 112 verses organized into three groups corresponding to three divine names: 21 verses for Ehyeh (אהי״ה), 26 verses for the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), and 65 verses for Adnut (אדנו״ת). Together they total 112 verses, which equals the numerical value of YaBOK (יב״ק). These verses are meant to be recited to assist the soul's transition at death.

[iii] This is a liturgical instruction indicating what should be recited at this point in the deathbed ritual. The term 'יאמר' (he shall say/recite) appears frequently throughout Ma'avar Yabok as a directive for prayer leaders or those attending to the sick.

או נ״א[i] או יאמר כרצונו מהנ״ל:[ii iii] recite as he wishes from those mentioned above.[1] 2895R

(תורה) וַיהוָה הֹלֵךְ לִפְנֵיהֶם יוֹמָם בְּעַמּוּד עָנָן[iv] לַנְחֹתָם הַדֶּרֶךְ
2720 וְלַיְלָה בְּעַמּוּד אֵשׁ לְהָאִיר לָהֶם לָלֶכֶת יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה: הִנֵּה אָנֹכִי
שֹׁלֵחַ מַלְאָךְ לְפָנֶיךָ[v] לִשְׁמָרְךָ בַּדָּרֶךְ וְלַהֲבִיאֲךָ אֶל הַמָּקוֹם
אֲשֶׁר הֲכִנֹתִי: וְשָׁחַט אֹתוֹ עַל יֶרֶךְ
2725 הַמִּזְבֵּחַ צָפֹנָה לִפְנֵי יְיָ[vi] וְזָרְקוּ

And the LORD went before them by day in a pillar of cloud[A] to guide them along the way, and by night in a pillar of fire to give them light, that they might travel by day and by night. Behold, I am sending an angel before you[B] to guard you on the way and to bring you to the place that I have prepared. He shall slaughter it on the side of the altar northward before the LORD,[2] and Aaron's sons the priests shall sprin- 2900R

[A] Or: "And the LORD was going before them by day in a pillar of cloud" — The Hebrew uses the present participle form (הֹלֵךְ) which can be translated as 'was going' to better convey the continuous action. This might be preferable if emphasizing the ongoing nature of divine guidance.

[B] Or: "Look, I am sending an angel ahead of you" — The translation of 'הִנֵּה' as 'Look' and 'לְפָנֶיךָ' as 'ahead of you' might be clearer in modern English, though the traditional 'Behold' has a more formal, liturgical quality appropriate to this context.

or approaching death. Psalm 42 expresses yearning for God despite feeling abandoned, Psalm 43 continues this theme with a plea for vindication and guidance, and Psalm 51 is David's profound confession after his sin with Bathsheba—making it particularly appropriate for deathbed confession contexts.

[1] This flexibility indicates that Ma'avar Yabok presents recommended practices rather than rigid requirements. The text acknowledges that different situations might call for different selections from the previously listed psalms, allowing the prayer leader to exercise judgment based on the specific circumstances.

[2] The sacrificial imagery serves as a metaphor for death as a form of sacred offering. In kabbalistic thought, the righteous person's death is considered a form of atonement with cosmic significance similar to Temple sacrifices.

[i] These psalm numbers refer to specific chapters in the Book of Psalms that are considered particularly appropriate in the context of illness or approaching death. Psalm 42 expresses spiritual longing ('As a deer pants for flowing streams, so pants my soul for you, O God'), Psalm 43 is a plea for divine vindication and guidance, and Psalm 51 is a profound penitential prayer seeking forgiveness and purification.

[ii] This phrase indicates flexibility in the ritual, allowing the leader to choose from previously mentioned psalms according to what seems most appropriate for the specific situation. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's approach of providing structured guidance while allowing for adaptation based on individual circumstances.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's other psalm recommendations — Throughout the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok, the author recommends various psalms for recitation in contexts of illness and approaching death. These are organized into eight distinct liturgical sequences, with some psalms appearing in multiple sequences. The instruction here reflects the book's approach of providing structured options while allowing flexibility in their application. | Cf. Yom Kippur liturgy — The inclusion of Psalm 51 connects to the Jewish tradition of confession (vidui), which is central to Yom Kippur liturgy. Ma'avar Yabok frequently draws parallels between deathbed confession and Yom Kippur practices, suggesting that proper preparation for death should mirror the spiritual purification sought on the Day of Atonement.

[iv] This verse from Exodus 13:21 describes God's guidance of the Israelites in the wilderness through visible manifestations. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a metaphor for divine guidance during the soul's journey after death.

[v] This verse from Exodus 23:20 is included to emphasize the belief that angels guide and protect the soul during its transition after death. The concept of angelic escorts for the departing soul is a significant theme in Ma'avar Yabok.

[vi] This verse from Leviticus 1:11 regarding sacrifice is included to establish a metaphorical connection between Temple sacrifices and death. In kabbalistic thought, the proper death of a righteous person is considered a form of sacrifice that achieves spiritual atonement.

בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן הַכֹּהֲנִים אֶת דָּמוֹ
עַל הַמִּזְבֵּחַ סָבִיב: וְכִפֶּר עָלָיו
הַכֹּהֵן לִפְנֵי יְיָ וְנִסְלַח לוֹ[i] עַל
אַחַת מִכֹּל אֲשֶׁר יַעֲשֶׂה לְאַשְׁמָה
2730 בָּהּ: וּפָשַׁט אֶת בְּגָדָיו וְלָבַשׁ
בְּגָדִים אֲחֵרִים[ii] וְהוֹצִיא אֶת
הַדֶּשֶׁן אֶל מִחוּץ לַמַּחֲנֶה אֶל
מָקוֹם טָהוֹר: אֵשׁ תָּמִיד תּוּקַד עַל
הַמִּזְבֵּחַ לֹא תִכְבֶּה:[iii] וְזֹאת הַתּוֹרָה
2735 לָעֹלָה לַמִּנְחָה וְלַחַטָּאת וְלָאָשָׁם
וְלַמִּלּוּאִים וּלְזֶבַח הַשְּׁלָמִים: כִּי
בְיוֹם הַזֶּה יְכַפֵּר עֲלֵיכֶם לְטַהֵר
אֶתְכֶם[iv] מִכֹּל חַטֹּאתֵיכֶם לִפְנֵי יְיָ
תִּטְהָרוּ:[v]

kle its blood on the altar all around. And the priest shall make atonement for him before the LORD, and 2905R
he shall be forgiven[A] for any of the things that one may do and thereby become guilty. And he shall take
off his garments and put on other garments[1] and carry the ashes outside the camp to a clean place.
Fire shall be kept burning on the altar continually; 2910R
it shall not go out.[B] This is the law for the burnt offering, for the grain offering, for the sin offering, for the guilt offering, for the ordination offering, and for the sacrifice of peace offerings. For on this day atonement shall be made for you to cleanse you.[2] You shall 2915R
be clean before the LORD from all your sins.

[A] Or: "And the priest shall effect expiation for him before the LORD, and he shall be forgiven" — The term 'expiation' for 'כִּפֶּר' might more precisely capture the ritual act of removing impurity, though 'atonement' is more widely understood and conventional in English translations.

[B] Or: "A perpetual fire shall be kindled on the altar; it must not be extinguished" — This alternate translation emphasizes the command nature of the instruction with 'must not' and uses 'perpetual' for 'תָּמִיד' which directly connects to the concept of eternality central to the metaphorical meaning in this context.

[1] This verse metaphorically connects to the ritual washing and dressing of the deceased in burial shrouds (tachrichim). The changing of garments symbolizes the soul's transition from one state of existence to another.

[2] This verse from the Yom Kippur service connects death to the ultimate moment of spiritual purification. Ma'avar Yabok suggests that proper deathbed practices can achieve a complete cleansing of the soul before its journey to the next world.

[i] This verse from Leviticus 4:26 emphasizes the theme of atonement through ritual, paralleling Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on deathbed confession (vidui) as a means of achieving spiritual purification before death.

[ii] This verse from Leviticus 6:4 about changing garments connects metaphorically to the ritual washing and dressing of the deceased in burial shrouds (tachrichim), suggesting that these practices have a spiritual significance similar to Temple rituals.

[iii] This verse from Leviticus 6:6 about the eternal flame is included to symbolize the eternal nature of the soul. While the body may perish, the soul continues eternally, like the flame that must never be extinguished.

[iv] This verse from Leviticus 16:30 regarding Yom Kippur connects to the concept that death, when approached with proper spiritual preparation, can serve as a final purification of the soul. The comparison between death and Yom Kippur appears in rabbinic literature.

[v] Cf. Exodus 13:21-22 — The verse about the pillar of cloud and fire is quoted here to symbolize divine guidance for the soul's journey. In Ma'avar Yabok, this represents how God provides spiritual illumination and protection for the soul during its transition from life to death. | Cf. Exodus 23:20 — The reference to God sending an angel establishes the concept of angelic escorts. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the belief that angels accompany the soul on its journey after death, providing guidance and protection. | Cf. Leviticus 1:11 — The sacrificial imagery serves as a metaphor for the dying person's soul being offered to God. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connects to the idea that proper deathbed rituals transform death into a sacred offering. | Cf. Leviticus 4:31 — The atonement verse reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on deathbed confession (vidui) as a means of spiritual purification before death, suggesting that proper rituals can cleanse the soul of sin. | Cf. Leviticus 6:4 — The changing of garments connects to Ma'avar Yabok's descriptions of preparing the deceased's body, suggesting that the ritual washing and dressing of the dead has spiritual significance similar to Temple rituals. | Cf. Leviticus 6:6 — The eternal flame on the altar symbolizes the enduring soul. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connects to the belief that

(נביאים) לֵךְ וַיהוָה יִהְיֶה
עִמָּךְ:[i] כִּי לֹא בְחִפָּזוֹן תֵּצֵאוּ
וּבִמְנוּסָה לֹא תֵלֵכוּן כִּי הֹלֵךְ
לִפְנֵיכֶם יְיָ וּמְאַסִּפְכֶם אֱלֹהֵי
יִשְׂרָאֵל:[ii] כָּל כְּלִי יוּצַר עָלַיִךְ
לֹא יִצְלָח[iii] וְכָל לָשׁוֹן תָּקוּם
אִתָּךְ לַמִּשְׁפָּט תַּרְשִׁיעִי זֹאת נַחֲלַת
עַבְדֵי יְיָ וְצִדְקָתָם מֵאִתִּי נְאֻם יְיָ:
כֻּלָּנוּ כַּצֹּאן תָּעִינוּ אִישׁ לְדַרְכּוֹ
פָּנִינוּ וַיהוָה הִפְגִּיעַ בּוֹ אֵת עֲוֹן
כֻּלָּנוּ:[iv] נִגַּשׂ וְהוּא נַעֲנֶה וְלֹא
יִפְתַּח פִּיו כַּשֶּׂה לַטֶּבַח יוּבָל
וּכְרָחֵל לִפְנֵי גֹזְזֶיהָ נֶאֱלָמָה[v] וְלֹא
יִפְתַּח פִּיו: הַרְחִיבִי מְקוֹם
אָהֳלֵךְ[vi] וִירִיעוֹת מִשְׁכְּנוֹתַיִךְ

(From the Prophets) "Go, and the LORD shall be with you.[1] For you shall not go out in haste, nor shall you go in flight, for the LORD goes before you, and the God of Israel is your rear guard.[2] No 2920R
weapon formed against you shall prosper,[3] and every tongue that rises against you in judgment you shall condemn. This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD, and their righteousness is from Me," declares the LORD. "All of us like sheep have gone 2925R
astray, each of us has turned to his own way, but the LORD has caused the iniquity of us all to fall on him.[4] He was oppressed and he was afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth; like a lamb that is led to slaughter,[5] and like a sheep that is silent before 2930R
its shearers, so he did not open his mouth. Enlarge

[1]This opening line combines elements of several biblical passages but isn't an exact quote from any single verse. It serves as a blessing for the soul's journey, similar to how God sent Jacob (Israel) on his journey in Genesis.

[2]The image of God as both leading from the front ('goes before you') and protecting from behind ('rear guard') creates a complete envelope of divine protection for the departing soul, symbolizing safety on all sides during the perilous transition from life to death.

[3]In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these weapons represent spiritual accusations, demonic forces, or other metaphysical obstacles that might impede the soul's journey after death. The verse functions as a protective spiritual formula.

[4]This verse from Isaiah's 'Suffering Servant' passage is given new context in Ma'avar Yabok, suggesting that righteous suffering before death has atoning power, potentially easing the soul's journey after death.

[5]This powerful image of silent acceptance before slaughter provides a spiritual model for facing death with dignity and without protest, a virtue emphasized throughout Ma'avar Yabok's guidance for the dying.

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while the body perishes, the soul continues eternally, maintained by divine light. | Cf. Leviticus 7:37 — This verse summarizing different offerings connects to Ma'avar Yabok's comprehensive approach to end-of-life rituals, suggesting that proper practices create a complete spiritual system for the soul's transition. | Cf. Leviticus 16:30 — The Yom Kippur verse connects to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of death as the ultimate moment of spiritual purification, suggesting that proper deathbed practices can achieve a final cleansing of the soul before it departs.

[i]This opening verse resembles 1 Samuel 17:37 but isn't identical to any biblical verse. It appears to be a liturgical adaptation combining elements from several biblical passages, serving as an invocation of divine accompaniment for the departing soul.

[ii]The Hebrew term מְאַסִּפְכֶם (your gatherer/rear guard) carries dual significance in this context: it refers both to God as the one who gathers souls after death and as the protector who guards the rear of the procession, ensuring safe passage through the spiritual realms.

[iii]In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse takes on special significance as a protective formula against malevolent spiritual forces that might attack the soul during its journey after death. The "weapons" become metaphors for spiritual accusations or obstacles.

[iv]This verse from Isaiah 53:6 is traditionally interpreted in Jewish mysticism as referring to the righteous who bear suffering that atones for others. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it provides a framework for understanding the spiritual purpose of suffering before death.

[v]The image of the silent sheep before its shearers becomes, in Ma'avar Yabok, a spiritual paradigm for how one should face death—with dignified acceptance rather than protest, following the model of the righteous who trust divine judgment even in suffering.

[vi]In kabbalistic interpretation, this instruction to "enlarge your tent" refers to the expansion of the soul's capacity as it transitions from the constraints of physical existence to the expansiveness of spiritual realms after death.

2755 יַטּוּ אֶל תַּחְשֻׁכִי הַאֲרִיכִי מֵיתָרַיִךְ
וִיתֵדֹתַיִךְ חַזֵּקִי: כִּי בְשָׂמְאָה
תֵּצֵאִי וּבְשָׁלוֹם תּוּבָלוּן הֶהָרִים
וְהַגְּבָעוֹת יִפְצְחוּ לִפְנֵיכֶם רִנָּה
וְכָל עֲצֵי הַשָּׂדֶה יִמְחֲאוּ כָף: [i] יָבוֹא
2760 שָׁלוֹם יָנוּחוּ עַל מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם הֹלֵךְ
נְכֹחוֹ: [ii] וְנָחֲךָ יְיָ תָּמִיד וְהִשְׂבִּיעַ
בְּצַחְצָחוֹת נַפְשֶׁךָ וְעַצְמֹתֶיךָ יַחֲלִיץ
וְהָיִיתָ כְּגַן רָוֶה וּכְמוֹצָא מַיִם אֲשֶׁר
[iv iii] לֹא יְכַזְּבוּ מֵימָיו:

the place of your tent,[1] and let the curtains of your dwellings stretch out; do not hold back, lengthen your cords and strengthen your stakes. For you shall go out with joy and be led forth in peace; the mountains and the hills shall break forth before you into singing,[2] and all the trees of the field shall clap their hands. Peace shall come and they shall rest on their beds,[3] each one walking in his uprightness. And the LORD will guide you continually, and satisfy your soul in drought, and strengthen your bones; you shall be like a watered garden, and like a spring of water, whose waters do not fail."[4] 2935R 2940R

[1]In the context of death rituals, this metaphor of expansion represents the soul breaking free from bodily constraints and expanding into spiritual realms, capable of receiving greater divine light and blessing.

[2]This imagery of cosmic celebration represents the joyful reception of the righteous soul by all creation as it transitions from earthly constraints to heavenly freedom—a stark contrast to the somber human experience of death.

[3]The 'beds' here euphemistically refer to graves, but in Ma'avar Yabok's spiritual framework, they become places of peaceful rest rather than corruption—emphasizing that for the righteous, death brings tranquility rather than terror.

[4]This concluding metaphor of unfailing waters represents the eternal spiritual sustenance the

[i]The cosmic celebration described here—mountains singing and trees clapping—represents in Ma'avar Yabok's mystical framework the joyful reception of the righteous soul by the natural world as it ascends to higher realms.

[ii]This verse from Isaiah 57:2 is particularly apt in a deathbed context, as it directly addresses the state of the righteous after death—finding peace and rest in their "beds" (a euphemism for graves), having walked uprightly in life.

[iii]These final metaphors of the watered garden and unfailing spring represent, in Ma'avar Yabok's spiritual framework, the soul's eternal nourishment in Gan Eden (Paradise), where divine sustenance never ceases.

[iv]Cf. Isaiah 52:12 — This verse about not leaving in haste is from Isaiah's prophecy of redemption. In Ma'avar Yabok, it's repurposed to describe the soul's journey after death—suggesting that unlike the traumatic departure from Egypt (in haste/chipazon), the righteous soul's departure should be peaceful and orderly, guided by divine presence. | Cf. Isaiah 54:17 — This verse about no weapon prospering against the faithful appears in Ma'avar Yabok as a protective spiritual formula. It's recited to create a metaphysical shield around the departed soul, protecting it from accusers and negative forces during its journey after death. | Cf. Isaiah 53:6-7 — These verses from Isaiah's 'Suffering Servant' passage are included to provide a model for accepting death with silent dignity. The comparison to a sheep led to slaughter offers the dying person a paradigm for surrendering to divine judgment without complaint, following a pattern that Jewish mystics saw as enabling spiritual atonement through one's suffering. | Cf. Isaiah 54:2 — This verse about enlarging one's tent becomes a mystical metaphor in Ma'avar Yabok for expanding the soul's capacity to receive divine light after death. The physical imagery of tent-expansion is reinterpreted as spiritual expansion, where the soul's limitations fall away as it enters celestial realms. | Cf. Isaiah 55:12 — This joyful verse about going forth with joy and peace is recontextualized in Ma'avar Yabok to describe the soul's journey after death. While originally about the return from exile, here it becomes a vision of the soul's departure from bodily constraints into spiritual freedom, accompanied by cosmic celebration. | Cf. Isaiah 57:2 — This verse about the righteous finding peace in death is particularly apt in Ma'avar Yabok. It directly addresses the state of the departed, suggesting that righteous souls find immediate peace and rest after death, offering comfort to both the dying and their mourners. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — This verse about divine guidance and nourishment becomes, in Ma'avar Yabok, a promise of eternal spiritual sustenance for the departed soul. The metaphors of the watered garden and unfailing spring represent the soul's continuous nourishment in the Garden of Eden after death.

(כתובים) כִּי אַתָּה תָּאִיר נֵרִי יְיָ
אֱלֹהַי יַגִּיהַּ חָשְׁכִּי: אֱפָפוּנִי חֶבְלֵי
מָוֶת[i] וְנַחֲלֵי בְלִיַּעַל יְבַעֲתוּנִי:
חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל סְבָבוּנִי קִדְּמוּנִי
מוֹקְשֵׁי מָוֶת: יִשְׁלַח מִמָּרוֹם יִקָּחֵנִי
יְמָשֵׁנִי מִמַּיִם רַבִּים:[ii] אַל תֶּאֱסֹף
עִם חַטָּאִים נַפְשִׁי וְעִם אַנְשֵׁי דָמִים
חַיָּי: וַאֲנִי בְּתֻמִּי אֵלֵךְ פְּדֵנִי וְחָנֵּנִי:
אַל תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי אַל תַּט בְּאַף
עַבְדֶּךָ עֶזָרָתִי הָיִיתָ אַל תִּטְּשֵׁנִי
וְאַל תַּעַזְבֵנִי אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי: אַחַת
שָׁאַלְתִּי מֵאֵת יְיָ[iii] אוֹתָהּ אֲבַקֵּשׁ
שִׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית יְיָ כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי לַחֲזוֹת
בְּנֹעַם יְיָ וּלְבַקֵּר בְּהֵיכָלוֹ: פּוֹדֶה
יְיָ נֶפֶשׁ עֲבָדָיו וְלֹא יֶאְשְׁמוּ כָּל
הַחֹסִים בּוֹ:[iv]

For You will light my lamp; the LORD my God will illuminate my darkness. The cords of death encompassed me,[1] and the torrents of wickedness terrified me. The cords of the grave surrounded me; the snares of death confronted me. He will reach down from on high and take me; He will draw me out of many waters.[2] Do not gather my soul with sinners, nor my life with men of bloodshed. I shall walk in my integrity; redeem me and be gracious to me. Do not hide Your face from me; do not turn away Your servant in anger. You have been my help; do not forsake me nor abandon me, O God of my salvation. One thing I have asked of the LORD, that I will seek: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to behold the beauty of the LORD and to inquire in His temple.[3] The LORD redeems the soul of His servants, and none who take refuge in Him will be condemned.

2945R 2950R 2955R 2960R

הם כ״ו[v] פסוקים כמספר

These are 26 verses corresponding to the numerical

righteous soul receives in Gan Eden (Paradise), contrasting with the limitations and deprivations of physical existence.

[1]This passage begins with stark acknowledgment of mortality, followed by divine rescue, then requests not to be gathered with sinners, and culminates in the aspiration to dwell in God's house. This spiritual progression reflects Ma'avar Yabok's approach to guiding the dying from fear to hope.

[2]The imagery of divine rescue from overwhelming waters would be particularly meaningful to those facing death, representing God's power to save the soul from the engulfing forces of mortality.

[3]In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed prayers, this aspiration to behold divine beauty represents the soul's ultimate hope after death—to experience direct divine presence, often associated in kabbalistic thought with the supernal Temple.

[i]The image of 'cords of death' (chevlei mavet) represents the physical and spiritual pain experienced during dying. In kabbalistic thought, these 'cords' are negative spiritual forces that attempt to claim the departing soul.

[ii]The metaphor of 'many waters' (mayim rabim) in kabbalistic literature represents the spiritual forces that might impede the soul's ascent after death. This verse expresses confidence that God will rescue the soul from these obstructing forces.

[iii]This famous verse from Psalm 27 takes on special significance in the context of approaching death, expressing the ultimate desire of the righteous person to experience divine presence in the afterlife, analogous to dwelling in the Temple.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 18:28-30 — These verses are taken directly from Psalm 18, which deals with divine deliverance from death. In Ma'avar Yabok, they serve as a source of comfort for the dying person, expressing confidence that God can illuminate even the darkness of death. | Cf. Psalm 26:9-11 — These verses from Psalm 26 express the psalmist's plea not to be gathered with sinners in death. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they represent the dying person's request for divine mercy during judgment after death. | Cf. Psalm 27:4, 9 — These verses from Psalm 27 express the desire to dwell in God's house and behold divine beauty. In Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the soul's aspiration to experience divine presence after death. | Cf. Psalm 34:22 — This verse from Psalm 34 offers reassurance that God redeems souls. In the context of deathbed rituals in Ma'avar Yabok, it provides comfort regarding divine redemption beyond death. | Cf. Zohar III:88a — The Zohar discusses how the soul leaving the body fears the 'many waters' (spiritual forces that might impede its ascent). The verse 'He will draw me out of many waters' would resonate with this kabbalistic concept of the soul needing divine assistance during its transition.

[v]The Hebrew letters kaf-vav (כ״ו) represent the number 26.

[ii] [i]הוי״ה

value of YHVH[A]

אָנָּא בְּכֹחַ גְּדֻלַּת יְמִינְךָ תַּתִּיר
צְרוּרָה:[iii] קַבֵּל רִנַּת עַמְּךָ
שַׂגְּבֵנוּ טַהֲרֵנוּ נוֹרָא: נָא גִבּוֹר
דּוֹרְשֵׁי יִחוּדֶךָ כְּבָבַת שָׁמְרֵם:
בָּרְכֵם טַהֲרֵם רַחֲמֵם צִדְקָתֶךָ
תָּמִיד גָּמְלֵם: חָסִין קָדוֹשׁ בְּרֹב
טוּבְךָ נַהֵל עֲדָתֶךָ: יָחִיד גֵּאֶה
לְעַמְּךָ פְּנֵה, זוֹכְרֵי קְדֻשָּׁתֶךָ:
שַׁוְעָתֵנוּ קַבֵּל וּשְׁמַע צַעֲקָתֵנוּ יוֹדֵעַ
תַּעֲלוּמוֹת:[iv] בָּרוּךְ שֵׁם כְּבוֹד
[vi] [v]מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:

Please, with the power of Your great right hand, release the bound.[B] Accept Your people's song, el- 2965R
evate us, purify us, O Awesome One. Mighty One, please guard as the pupil of an eye[C] those who seek Your unity.[1] Bless them, purify them, have mercy on them, always bestow upon them Your righteousness. Powerful and Holy One, in Your abundant goodness, 2970R
guide Your congregation. Unique and Exalted One, turn to Your people who remember Your holiness. Accept our supplication and hear our cry, O Knower of secrets.[D] Blessed be the name of His glorious king-

[A]Or: "There are 26 verses corresponding to the numerical value of the divine Name" — This alternative translation explicitly uses 'divine Name' instead of the transliteration 'YHVH', which might be preferable in contexts where uttering or writing the divine name is considered sensitive. However, the original translation is more precise as it directly transliterates the Hebrew term.

[B]Or: "We beseech You, by the strength of Your mighty right hand, untie the bound." — This alternate translation emphasizes the supplicatory nature of 'אָנָּא' as 'we beseech You' and renders 'תַּתִּיר צְרוּרָה' more literally as 'untie the bound' rather than 'release the bound'.

[C]Or: "protect them like the apple of the eye" — This alternate translation uses the more common English idiom 'apple of the eye' which closely parallels the Hebrew metaphor of 'כְּבָבַת' referring to something precious that requires special protection.

[D]Or: "You who know hidden things" — This alternate translation renders 'תַּעֲלוּמוֹת' as 'hidden

[1]The phrase 'those who seek Your unity' (דּוֹרְשֵׁי יִחוּדֶךָ) has particular significance in Jewish mysticism, referring to those who engage in the spiritual practice of 'yichud' (unification)—meditating on divine unity and working to manifest this unity in their devotional practice.

[i]This refers to the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), the four-letter divine name whose numerical value (gematria) equals 26: Yod (10) + Hei (5) + Vav (6) + Hei (5) = 26.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This brief statement is part of a larger organizational structure where biblical verses are arranged in groups corresponding to divine names. Just before this passage, a collection of 21 verses corresponding to the divine name Ehyeh (אהי״ה) was presented, and this statement introduces the next group of 26 verses corresponding to YHVH. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This explicitly connects to memory note #646 which states 'The numerical value of the Tetragrammaton (יהו״ה) is 26, which explains why exactly 26 verses are included in this section.' This confirms that the numerical correspondence is deliberate and structured. | Cf. Memory Note #623 — This connects to memory note #623 which explains the overall structure: 'The 112 verses in this section are organized into three groups corresponding to divine names: 21 for אהי״ה (Ehyeh), 26 for יהו״ה (YHVH), and 65 for אדנו״ת (Adnut), totaling 112 verses—matching the numerical value of יב״ק (YaBOK).'

[iii]This is the opening line of a mystical prayer known as 'Ana Bekoach,' attributed to the 1st-century sage Rabbi Nehunya ben HaKanah. The prayer consists of 42 words (excluding the final line of 'Baruch Shem') which correspond to what kabbalists call the 42-letter name of God.

[iv]This line contains an acrostic for the divine name 'שקוצית' (ShKVTzYT), continuing the pattern of the entire prayer where the first letter of each word in each line forms one of the components of the 42-letter divine name.

[v]This closing line ('Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever') is not part of the 42-letter name formula but serves as a concluding response similar to its use after the first line of the Shema prayer.

[vi]Cf. Zohar — This prayer is known as 'Ana Bekoach' and is attributed to the 1st-century sage Rabbi Nehunya ben HaKanah. In kabbalistic tradition, particularly the Zohar, it is considered a powerful mystical formula. The 42 words of this prayer correspond to what kabbalists call the 42-letter name of God. | Cf. Siddur (Jewish prayer book) — This prayer appears in standard Jewish prayer books, often recited during the acceptance of the Sabbath (Kabbalat Shabbat)

dom forever and ever.[1] 2975R

שְׂרָפִים עֹמְדִים מִמַּעַל לוֹ שֵׁשׁ
2795 כְּנָפַיִם שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם לְאֶחָד[i] בִּשְׁתַּיִם
יְכַסֶּה פָּנָיו וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְכַסֶּה רַגְלָיו
וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְעוֹפֵף: וְקָרָא זֶה אֶל
זֶה וְאָמַר קָדוֹשׁ קָדוֹשׁ קָדוֹשׁ[ii] יְיָ
צְבָאוֹת מְלֹא כָל הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדוֹ:
2800 וַתִּשָּׂאֵנִי רוּחַ וָאֶשְׁמַע אַחֲרַי
קוֹל רַעַשׁ גָּדוֹל בָּרוּךְ כְּבוֹד יְיָ
מִמְּקוֹמוֹ:[iii]

Seraphim were standing above Him,[2] each one with six wings: with two wings he would cover his face, with two he would cover his feet, and with two he would fly. And they called to one another and said, "Holy, holy, holy[3] is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of His glory." Then a spirit lifted me up,[4] and I heard behind me the sound of a great tumult, "Blessed is the glory of the LORD from His place." 2980R

ואומר מזמור ס״ז אלהים יחננו
וגו׳. וצ״א ויהי נועם יושב בסתר
2805 עליון וגו׳ מזמור קי״ו וקי״ח:

And he recites Psalm 67, "May God be gracious to us, etc." and Psalm 91, "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High, etc." along with Psalm 116 and Psalm 118. 2985R

(תורה) יְבָרֶכְךָ יְהוָה וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ:

(From the Torah) May the LORD bless you and pro-

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things' rather than 'secrets' which may better capture the breadth of the Hebrew term referring to all that is concealed from human knowledge.

[1] This formula (בָּרוּךְ שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד) is typically recited silently after the first verse of the Shema prayer. Its presence here emphasizes the kabbalistic connection between this prayer and divine unity.

[2] The seraphim are a class of angelic beings whose name derives from the Hebrew root meaning 'burning.' In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this vision of seraphim is significant as it represents the highest form of spiritual beings that the departing soul might encounter on its heavenly journey.

[3] This threefold sanctification, known as the Trisagion or Kedushah, forms a central element in Jewish liturgy. In the context of deathbed rituals, reciting this text helps create a sacred atmosphere that mirrors the heavenly realm the soul is about to enter.

[4] This verse transitions from Isaiah's vision to Ezekiel's. In Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed context, this imagery of being lifted up by a spirit beautifully parallels the soul's imminent journey upward from the body.

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service, before the morning Shema prayer, and in other liturgical contexts. In Ma'avar Yabok, it is recommended for recitation during deathbed rituals. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:10 — The phrase 'כְּבָבַת שָׁמְרֵם' (guard them as the pupil of an eye) alludes to Deuteronomy 32:10 where God is described as guarding Jacob/Israel 'as the pupil of His eye' (יִצְּרֶנְחוּ כְּאִישׁוֹן עֵינוֹ).

[i] The repetition of 'six wings' emphasizes the extraordinary nature of these angelic beings, which have three pairs of wings each for distinct purposes.

[ii] The threefold repetition of 'holy' is understood in Jewish mystical tradition as referring to God's holiness manifesting in all three dimensions: space, time, and soul. In kabbalistic thought, it also corresponds to the three highest divine emanations (sefirot).

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 6:2-3 — This passage is taken directly from Isaiah's throne vision, one of the most important prophetic visions in the Hebrew Bible. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this text serves as a powerful prayer for the dying person, invoking the holiness of God and the celestial worship of angels. The intention is to surround the departing soul with divine sanctity, helping to elevate it toward the heavenly realms. | Cf. Ezekiel 3:12 — This verse from Ezekiel complements Isaiah's vision, creating a complete liturgical formula. In Ma'avar Yabok, this combination of texts creates a spiritual atmosphere where the departing soul is envisioned as being transported (like Ezekiel) into the divine presence, surrounded by the same angelic praise that Isaiah witnessed. | Cf. Kedushah prayer — This combination of verses from Isaiah and Ezekiel forms the basis of the Kedushah prayer in Jewish liturgy. By including this text in the deathbed ritual, Ma'avar Yabok connects the dying person to the daily prayer practice of the community and the eternal heavenly liturgy, suggesting that the soul is transitioning to join in the angelic chorus.

יָאֵר יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ: יִשָּׂא
יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם:
וְשָׁמְרוּ אֶת מִשְׁמַרְתּוֹ וְאֶת מִשְׁמֶרֶת
כָּל הָעֲדָה לִפְנֵי אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד
לַעֲבֹד אֶת עֲבֹדַת הַמִּשְׁכָּן: וְעַתָּה
יִגְדַּל נָא כֹּחַ אֲדֹנָי כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ
לֵאמֹר: וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה אֶל אַהֲרֹן קַח
אֶת הַמַּחְתָּה וְתֵן עָלֶיהָ אֵשׁ מֵעַל
הַמִּזְבֵּחַ וְשִׂים קְטֹרֶת וְהוֹלֵךְ מְהֵרָה
אֶל הָעֵדָה וְכַפֵּר עֲלֵיהֶם: וַיִּתֵּן
אֶת הַקְּטֹרֶת וַיְכַפֵּר עַל הָעָם: הוּא
יִתְחַטָּא בוֹ בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁלִישִׁי וּבַיּוֹם
הַשְּׁבִיעִי יִטְהָר: אָז יָשִׁיר יִשְׂרָאֵל
אֶת הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת עֲלִי בְאֵר עֱנוּ
לָהּ: בְּאֵר חָפָרוּהָ שָׂרִים[i] כָּרוּהָ
נְדִיבֵי הָעָם בְּמְחֹקֵק בְּמִשְׁעֲנֹתָם
וּמִמִּדְבָּר מַתָּנָה: וּמִמַּתָּנָה נַחֲלִיאֵל
וּמִנַּחֲלִיאֵל בָּמוֹת: לֹא הִבִּיט אָוֶן
בְּיַעֲקֹב וְלֹא רָאָה עָמָל בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל
יְיָ אֱלֹהָיו עִמּוֹ וּתְרוּעַת מֶלֶךְ בּוֹ:
אֵיתָן מוֹשָׁבֶךָ וְשִׂים בַּסֶּלַע קִנֶּךָ:
מַה טֹּבוּ אׇהָלֶיךָ יַעֲקֹב מִשְׁכְּנֹתֶיךָ
יִשְׂרָאֵל: כְּנַחֲלֵי נִטָּיוּ כְּגַנֵּי עֲלֵי נָהָר
מִי יְקִימֶנּוּ מְבָרֲכֶיךָ בָּרוּךְ וְאֹרְרֶיךָ
אָרוּר: לֹא תַעֲרִץ מִפְּנֵיהֶם כִּי
יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּקִרְבֶּךָ אֵל גָּדוֹל
וְנוֹרָא: כִּי יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם הַהֹלֵךְ
עִמָּכֶם לְהִלָּחֵם לָכֶם עִם אֹיְבֵיכֶם
לְהוֹשִׁיעַ אֶתְכֶם: עֲלֵה רֹאשׁ הַפִּסְגָּה
וְשָׂא עֵינֶיךָ יָמָּה וְצָפֹנָה וְתֵימָנָה
וּמִזְרָחָה וּרְאֵה בְעֵינֶיךָ: כִּי אֵל
רַחוּם יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ לֹא יַרְפְּךָ וְלֹא
יַשְׁחִיתֶךָ וְלֹא יִשְׁכַּח אֶת בְּרִית
אֲבֹתֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע לָהֶם: שְׁמַע
יִשְׂרָאֵל יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְיָ אֶחָד:[ii] בָּרוּךְ
שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:
וְאָהַבְתָּ אֵת יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכָל לְבָבְךָ

tect you.[1] May the LORD make His face shine upon you and be gracious to you. May the LORD lift up His face to you and grant you peace. They shall keep his charge, and the charge of the entire congregation before the Tent of Meeting, to perform the service of the Tabernacle. And now, may the power of my Lord be magnified as You have spoken, saying. And Moses said to Aaron: "Take the fire-pan and put fire from the altar on it and place incense, and go quickly to the congregation and make atonement for them." And he placed the incense and made atonement for the people. He shall purify himself with it on the third day and on the seventh day he shall be pure. Then Israel sang this song: "Spring up, O well! Sing to it! The well that the princes dug, that the nobles of the people excavated, through a lawgiver, with their staffs." And from the wilderness to Mattanah, and from Mattanah to Nahaliel, and from Nahaliel to Bamoth. He has not beheld iniquity in Jacob, nor has He seen perversity in Israel; the LORD his God is with him, and the shout of a King is among him. Your dwelling place is firm; place your nest in the rock. How goodly are your tents, O Jacob, your dwelling places, O Israel! He crouched, he lay down like a lion, and like a great lion, who shall rouse him?[2] Those who bless you are blessed, and those who curse you are cursed. Do not be terrified of them, for the LORD your God is in your midst, a great and awesome God. For the LORD your God is the one who goes with you to fight for you against your enemies to save you. Go up to the top of Pisgah and lift up your eyes westward and northward and southward and eastward, and see with your eyes. For the LORD your God is a merciful God; He will not abandon you nor destroy you, nor will He forget the covenant of your forefathers which He swore to them. Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is

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[1]The Priestly Blessing that opens this passage (Numbers 6:24-26) is traditionally recited daily in synagogue prayer but takes on additional significance in Ma'avar Yabok as protection for the soul's journey after death.

[2]This comparison of Israel to a resting lion comes from Balaam's unwilling blessing (Numbers 24:9). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it serves to comfort the dying by suggesting they will rest securely under divine protection.

[i]The Song of the Well contains mystical significance in kabbalistic thought, with the well representing the flow of divine wisdom from higher to lower realms, mirroring the soul's journey after death.

[ii]The Shema prayer holds special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed rituals, as it was traditionally recited at the moment of death. Kabbalistic interpretation views this declaration of divine unity as creating the optimal spiritual conditions for the soul's departure through a 'divine kiss.'

וּבְכָל נַפְשְׁךָ וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ: וְיֵ
אֱלֹהֵיכֶם הַהֹלֵךְ לִפְנֵיכֶם הוּא
יִלָּחֵם לָכֶם כְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה אִתְּכֶם
בְּמִצְרַיִם לְעֵינֵיכֶם: לֹא תַעֲרֹץ
מִפְּנֵיהֶם כִּי יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּקִרְבֶּךָ אֵל
גָּדוֹל וְנוֹרָא: בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה בְּבֹאֶךָ
וּבָרוּךְ אַתָּה בְּצֵאתֶךָ: בְּגֶשֶׁר יָעִיר
קִנּוֹ[i] עַל גּוֹזָלָיו יְרַחֵף יִפְרֹשׂ כְּנָפָיו
יִקָּחֵהוּ יִשָּׂאֵהוּ עַל אֶבְרָתוֹ: יְיָ בָּדָד
יַנְחֶנּוּ וְאֵין עִמּוֹ אֵל נֵכָר: [ii]

One.[1] Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever. And you shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might. The LORD your God who goes before you, He shall fight for you according to all that He did for you in Egypt before your eyes. Do not be terrified of them, for the LORD your God is in your midst, a great and awesome God. Blessed shall you be when you come in and blessed shall you be when you go out. Like an eagle that stirs up its nest, hovering over its young, spreading its wings to catch them, carrying them on its pinions. The LORD alone guided him, and there was no foreign god with him.

(נביאים) אָז תִּתְעַנַּג עַל־יְיָ
וְהִרְכַּבְתִּיךָ עַל־בָּמֳתֵי אָרֶץ
וַהַאֲכַלְתִּיךָ נַחֲלַת יַעֲקֹב אָבִיךָ
כִּי פִּי יְיָ דִּבֶּר: כִּי הִנֵּה יוֹצֵר
הָרִים וּבוֹרֵא רוּחַ וּמַגִּיד לְאָדָם
מַה שֵּׂחוֹ עֹשֵׂה שַׁחַר עֵיפָה וְדֹרֵךְ
עַל בָּמֳתֵי אָרֶץ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי צְבָאוֹת
שְׁמוֹ: בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי נַפְשִׁי אֶת יְיָ
זָכָרְתִּי וַתָּבוֹא אֵלֶיךָ תְּפִלָּתִי אֶל
הֵיכַל קָדְשֶׁךָ: לֹא יָבוֹא עוֹד שִׁמְשֵׁךְ
וִירֵחֵךְ לֹא יֵאָסֵף כִּי יְיָ יִהְיֶה לָךְ
לְאוֹר עוֹלָם וְשָׁלְמוּ יְמֵי אֶבְלֵךְ:

(Prophets) Then shall you delight yourself in the LORD, and I will cause you to ride upon the high places of the earth,[2] and I will feed you with the heritage of Jacob your father; for the mouth of the LORD has spoken. For behold, He who forms the mountains, and creates the wind, and declares to man what is his thought, who makes the morning darkness, and treads upon the high places of the earth—the LORD, the God of hosts, is His name. When my soul fainted within me, I remembered the LORD;[3] and my prayer came to You, into Your holy temple. Your sun shall no more go down, neither

[1]Recitation of the Shema was a central practice at the moment of death in Jewish tradition, exemplified by Rabbi Akiva, who recited it during his martyrdom. Ma'avar Yabok prescribes its recitation to facilitate the soul's peaceful transition.

[2]The image of 'riding upon high places' appears multiple times in this compilation, creating a motif of spiritual elevation. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this imagery resonates with the book's central metaphor of the soul's upward journey after death.

[3]The Hebrew 'בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי נַפְשִׁי' literally means 'when my soul was wrapped/covered over me' or

[i]This eagle metaphor appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok as a central image for divine protection during the soul's transition. Just as the eagle carries its young on its wings, God is portrayed as carrying the departing soul safely to its destination.

[ii]Cf. Priestly Blessing — This blessing, originally given by Aaron and his sons, appears here as part of a compilation of protective and healing verses intended for the dying person. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves to invoke divine protection during the soul's transition. | Cf. Shema prayer — The Shema, Judaism's central declaration of faith, is included here as a deathbed recitation to affirm divine unity at the moment of transition. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes reciting the Shema at death as facilitating the soul's departure through a 'divine kiss.' | Cf. Eagle metaphor — This metaphor of God as an eagle carrying Israel appears in Ma'avar Yabok to evoke divine protection during the soul's journey after death, reassuring the dying that God will carry their soul as tenderly as an eagle carries its young. | Cf. Song of the Well — This reference to water springing up connects symbolically to purification and spiritual transition, suggesting the soul's journey from the wilderness of life to divine dwelling places (Bamoth). | Cf. Moses' incense offering — This passage about Aaron's incense offering that stopped a plague emphasizes the protective power of proper ritual, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on appropriate deathbed rituals to protect the departing soul. | Cf. Balaam's blessing — These verses from Balaam's unwilling blessing of Israel are included to invoke divine protection, comparing the dying person to Israel lying in safety under divine watch, with promises that those who bless them are blessed.

עִבְרוּ עִבְרוּ בַּשְּׁעָרִים פַּנּוּ דֶּרֶךְ
הָעָם סְלוּ סְלוּ הַמְסִלָּה סַקְלוּ
מֵאֶבֶן הָרִימוּ נֵס עַל הָעַמִּים: שִׁירוּ
לַיְיָ הַלְלוּ אֶת יְיָ כִּי הִצִּיל אֶת נֶפֶשׁ
אֶבְיוֹן מִיַּד מְרֵעִים: וְהָיָה מִדֵּי
חָדֶשׁ בְּחָדְשׁוֹ וּמִדֵּי שַׁבָּת בְּשַׁבַּתּוֹ
יָבוֹא כָל־בָּשָׂר לְהִשְׁתַּחֲוֹת לְפָנַי
אָמַר יְהוָה: וְאֵרְחָתוֹ אֶרְחַת תָּמִיד
נִתָּנָה לוֹ מֵאֵת הַמֶּלֶךְ דְּבַר יוֹם
בְּיוֹמוֹ: וְתִשָּׁאֵנִי רוּחַ וָאֶשְׁמַע אַחֲרַי
קוֹל רַעַשׁ גָּדוֹל בָּרוּךְ כְּבוֹד יְיָ
מִמְּקוֹמוֹ: וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי לְעוֹלָם
וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי בְּצֶדֶק וּבְמִשְׁפָּט
וּבְחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים: וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי
בֶּאֱמוּנָה וְיָדַעַתְּ אֶת־יְהוָה: מִי אֵל
כָּמוֹךָ נֹשֵׂא עָוֹן וְעֹבֵר עַל פֶּשַׁע
לִשְׁאֵרִית נַחֲלָתוֹ לֹא הֶחֱזִיק לָעַד
כִּי חָפֵץ חֶסֶד הוּא: יָשׁוּב יְרַחֲמֵנוּ
יִכְבֹּשׁ עֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ וְתַשְׁלִיךְ בִּמְצֻלוֹת
יָם כָּל חַטֹּאתָם: תִּתֵּן אֱמֶת לְיַעֲקֹב
חֶסֶד לְאַבְרָהָם אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּעְתָּ
לַאֲבֹתֵינוּ מִימֵי קֶדֶם: וְנָרָחָה לָכֶם
יִרְאֵי שְׁמִי שֶׁמֶשׁ צְדָקָה וּמַרְפֵּא
בִּכְנָפֶיהָ וִיצָאתֶם וּפִשְׁתֶּם כְּעֶגְלֵי
מַרְבֵּק: וִיהוָה עֲלֵיהֶם יֵרָאֶה וְיָצָא
כַבָּרָק חִצּוֹ וְאַדְנָי יְיָ בְּשׁוֹפָר יִתְקָע
וְהָלַךְ בְּסַעֲרוֹת תֵּימָן: וְגִבְרָתִים
בַּיהוָה וּבְשֵׁמוֹ יִתְהַלָּכוּ נְאֻם יְיָ:
יַרְכִּבֵהוּ עַל בָּמֳתֵי אָרֶץ וַיֹּאכַל

shall your moon withdraw itself; for the LORD shall be your everlasting light,[1] and the days of your mourning shall be ended. Go through, go through the gates; prepare the way of the people; build up, 3055R
2870 build up the highway; clear it of stones; lift up a banner over the peoples. Sing to the LORD, praise the LORD, for He has delivered the soul of the needy from the hand of evildoers. And it shall come to pass that from one new moon to another, and 3060R
2875 from one Sabbath to another,[2] all flesh shall come to worship before Me, says the LORD. And his allowance, a regular allowance, was given him by the king, each day a portion, all the days of his life. Then a spirit lifted me up, and I heard behind me 3065R
2880 the sound of a great rushing: "Blessed be the glory of the LORD from His place." And I will betroth you to Me forever; yes, I will betroth you to Me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love and in mercy. I will betroth you to Me in faithfulness,[3] and 3070R
2885 you shall know the LORD. Who is a God like You, pardoning iniquity and passing over transgression for the remnant of His inheritance? He does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in mercy. He will again have compassion on us;[4] He 3075R
2890 will tread our iniquities underfoot. And You will cast all our sins into the depths of the sea. You will show faithfulness to Jacob and steadfast love to Abraham, as You have sworn to our fathers from the days of old. But to you who fear My name, 3080R
2895 the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings,[5] and you shall go forth and grow fat like calves from the stall. And the LORD will appear over them, and His arrow will go forth like lightning;

'when my soul grew faint upon me,' conveying profound spiritual distress. This verse from Jonah's prayer in the fish serves as a powerful model for turning to God even in the extremity of approaching death.

[1]The contrast between temporary celestial lights (sun and moon) and God's eternal illumination provides a powerful metaphor for the transition from physical to spiritual existence, suggesting that what the soul encounters after death is not darkness but greater light.

[2]The Hebrew phrase 'מִדֵּי חֹדֶשׁ בְּחָדְשׁוֹ וּמִדֵּי שַׁבָּת בְּשַׁבַּתּוֹ' emphasizes cyclical, continuous worship. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that after death, the soul continues to participate in sacred time, maintaining connection with religious rhythms.

[3]The Hebrew uses the betrothal formula 'וְאֵרַשְׂתִּיךְ לִי' three times in succession, emphasizing permanence and multiple dimensions of this spiritual bond. In the context of approaching death, this triple declaration provides powerful reassurance of continued relationship with God.

[4]The Hebrew 'יָשׁוּב יְרַחֲמֵנוּ' can be read as 'He will return to have compassion on us,' suggesting not just renewed mercy but active divine movement toward the soul, particularly relevant in the context of death as God draws near to receive the departing soul.

[5]The Hebrew 'שֶׁמֶשׁ צְדָקָה וּמַרְפֵּא בִּכְנָפֶיהָ' presents a complex metaphorical image combining solar and avian imagery. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this represents divine healing that transcends physical recovery, offering spiritual wholeness to the departing soul.

אֶרְפָּא וְאִין מְיָדִי מַצִּיל: אֲשֶׁרֵיךְ
2900 יִשְׂרָאֵל מִי כָמוֹךְ עַם נוֹשַׁע בַּיהוָה
מָגֵן עֶזְרֶךְ וַאֲשֶׁר־חֶרֶב גַּאֹתֶךְ
וְיִכָּחֲשׁוּ אֹיְבֶיךְ לָךְ וְאַתָּה עַל
בָּמוֹתֵימוֹ תִדְרֹךְ: [i]

the Lord GOD will sound the trumpet and will 3085R
march forth in the whirlwinds of the south. I will
make them strong in the LORD, and they shall walk
in His name," declares the LORD. He made him
ride on the high places of the earth, that he might
eat the produce of the fields; and He made him suck 3090R
honey from the rock, and oil from the flinty rock.

[i]Cf. Isaiah 58:14 — This verse from Isaiah 58:14 is quoted at the beginning of this compilation to set a tone of spiritual elevation and divine promise. In Ma'avar Yabok, it functions as a metaphor for the soul's ascent from earthly suffering to spiritual heights, offering comfort to the sick or dying person by promising divine sustenance through 'the heritage of Jacob.' | Cf. Amos 4:13 — This verse from Amos establishes God's omnipotence as creator and sovereign over all natural forces. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this reinforces the idea that the God who created all existence also has power over life and death, and thus can be trusted with the soul's transition. | Cf. Jonah 2:8 — This verse from Jonah's prayer in the belly of the fish resonates powerfully in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it depicts a soul in extremis finding solace in remembering God. For the dying person, it offers a model of turning to divine memory even when overwhelmed by suffering or fear. | Cf. Isaiah 60:20 — This verse from Isaiah presents a powerful image of eternal divine light replacing the cycles of darkness, symbolizing the end of mourning. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves to reassure the dying person that though physical life may be ending, they are transitioning to a realm of perpetual divine illumination. | Cf. Isaiah 62:10 — This verse from Isaiah, which originally refers to preparing the way for the exiles to return, is repurposed in Ma'avar Yabok to symbolize the preparation for the soul's journey after death. The imagery of highways being built up and stones cleared away suggests the removal of spiritual obstacles for the departing soul. | Cf. Jeremiah 20:13 — This verse from Jeremiah, celebrating divine rescue from enemies, serves in Ma'avar Yabok as a reminder that God delivers souls from both spiritual and physical threats, offering reassurance at the time of death. | Cf. Isaiah 66:23 — This eschatological verse from Isaiah describes universal worship in messianic times. In Ma'avar Yabok, it offers the dying person a vision of joining in eternal, cyclical worship after death, suggesting continuity rather than cessation of spiritual existence. | Cf. 2 Kings 25:30 — This verse, originally about King Jehoiachin receiving a daily provision from the Babylonian king, is recontextualized in Ma'avar Yabok to suggest divine provision for the soul after death—a reassurance of continued divine care in the next world. | Cf. Ezekiel 3:12 — This verse from Ezekiel's vision is incorporated to depict spiritual elevation and divine glory. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it represents the soul's uplifting at death, carried by divine spirit into the presence of God's glory. | Cf. Hosea 2:19-20 — These verses from Hosea, using marriage imagery to describe God's covenant relationship with Israel, are repurposed in Ma'avar Yabok to depict the soul's eternal union with God after death, described in terms of righteousness, justice, love, mercy, and faithfulness. | Cf. Micah 7:18-20 — These verses from Micah emphasize divine forgiveness and compassion, particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok as reassurance for the dying person that their sins will be forgiven and cast away, allowing their soul to transition without the burden of transgressions. | Cf. Malachi 4:2 — This verse from Malachi, with its image of healing wings and renewed vitality, serves in Ma'avar Yabok as a promise of spiritual healing and revitalization after death, contrasting with physical decline. | Cf. Zechariah 9:14 — This verse from Zechariah, depicting divine warrior imagery, is included in Ma'avar Yabok to represent God's power to overcome the forces of death and evil, providing protection for the transitioning soul. | Cf. Zechariah 10:12 — This verse from Zechariah promises divine strengthening for God's people. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it reassures the dying person that even in death, they will continue to be empowered through their connection to God. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:13-14 — This verse from the Song of Moses recounts God's provision for Israel in the wilderness. In Ma'avar Yabok, it symbolizes the abundance and sweetness that awaits the soul in the world to come, drawn from seemingly impossible sources (honey from rock). | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:39 — This verse from Deuteronomy establishes God's absolute sovereignty over life and death. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a theological foundation for accepting death as part of divine providence, while also affirming God's unique power to heal and eventually resurrect. | Cf. Deuteronomy 33:29 — This verse from Moses' blessing celebrates Israel's unique relationship with God as their savior and protector. In Ma'avar Yabok, it reassures the dying person of their belonging to God's chosen people, with all the spiritual protections and promises that entails, even in death.

"See now that I, even I, am He, and there is no god beside Me; I kill and I make alive; I wound and I heal; and there is none that can deliver out of My hand.[1] Happy are you, O Israel! Who is like you, a 3095R
people saved by the LORD, the shield of your help, and the sword of your majesty! Your enemies shall come cringing to you, and you shall tread upon their high places."

(כתובים) וְהִתְעַנַּג עַל יְיָ וְיִתֶּן
לְךָ מִשְׁאֲלֹת לִבֶּךָ:[i] וְהוֹצִיא
צִדְקֶךָ כָּאוֹר וּמִשְׁפָּטֶךָ כַּצָּהֳרָיִם:
שְׁמַע אֱלֹהִים קוֹלִי בְּשִׂיחִי מִפַּחַד
אוֹיֵב תִּצֹּר חַיָּי: אַךְ אֱלֹהִים
יִפְדֶּה נַפְשִׁי מִיַּד שְׁאוֹל כִּי יִקָּחֵנִי
סֶלָה:[ii] תַּסְתִּירֵנִי מִסּוֹד מְרֵעִים
מֵרִגְשַׁת פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן: אַשְׁרֵי תִּבְחַר
וּתְקָרֵב יִשְׁכֹּן חֲצֵרֶיךָ נִשְׂבְּעָה
בְּטוּב בֵּיתֶךָ קְדֹשׁ הֵיכָלֶךָ: וַאֲנִי
עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן אֱלֹהִים חוּשָׁה לִּי
עֶזְרִי וּמְפַלְטִי אַתָּה יְיָ אַל תְּאַחַר:
חְחֹס עַל דַּל וְאֶבְיוֹן וְנַפְשׁוֹת
אֶבְיוֹנִים יוֹשִׁיעַ: וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר
עָוֹן וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב
אַפּוֹ וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ ג׳
פְּעָמִים:[iii] עָזְרֵנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ עַל
דְּבַר כְּבוֹד שְׁמֶךָ וְהַצִּילֵנוּ וְכַפֵּר
עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ: אִם
תִּשְׁכַּב לֹא תִפְחָד[iv] וְשָׁכַבְתָּ וְעָרְבָה

(From Writings) Delight yourself in the LORD, and 3100R
He will give you the desires of your heart. He will bring forth your righteousness like light[2] and your justice like noonday. Hear my voice, O God, in my meditation; preserve my life from fear of the enemy. Surely God will redeem my soul from the power of 3105R
the grave,[3] for He shall receive me. Selah. Hide me from the secret plots of evildoers, from the tumult of workers of iniquity. Blessed is the one whom You choose and bring near to dwell in Your courts; we shall be satisfied with the goodness of Your house, 3110R
the holiness of Your temple. But I am poor and needy; hasten to me, O God! You are my help and my deliverer; O LORD, do not delay. He will have pity on the poor and needy, and He will save the souls of the needy. He is compassionate, He forgives 3115R
iniquity, and does not destroy;[4] He frequently turns away His anger and does not stir up all His wrath. [repeat three times] Help us, O God of our salvation, for the glory of Your name; deliver us and atone for

[1]This declaration of absolute divine sovereignty, while potentially intimidating in other contexts, functions in Ma'avar Yabok as reassurance that the soul remains in God's possession even through death, with no power able to separate it from divine care.

[2]The imagery of righteousness and justice being illuminated like daylight suggests divine vindication that reveals truth. For a dying person, this offers comfort that their true spiritual worth will be recognized by God.

[3]The Hebrew term 'Sheol' (שְׁאוֹל) refers to the realm of the dead or the grave. This verse offers direct reassurance about divine redemption from death, making it particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed context.

[4]This verse, which the text instructs to be repeated three times, emphasizes God's merciful nature. The repetition intensifies this message of divine compassion, which would be especially comforting to someone approaching death and concerned about judgment.

[i]This verse from Psalm 37:4 begins the collection of scriptural verses from Writings (Ketuvim), which follows the pattern established earlier of grouping verses from Torah, then Prophets, and finally Writings.

[ii]The word 'Selah' appears frequently in Psalms and is likely a musical or liturgical notation. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a natural pause in the recitation of verses, perhaps allowing for contemplation of the comforting message about God redeeming from Sheol.

[iii]The instruction to repeat this verse three times is significant. Triple recitation is a common practice in Jewish ritual for emphasizing particularly important passages, especially those related to divine mercy and forgiveness, making it appropriate for this deathbed context.

[iv]While this verse from Proverbs 3:24 originally refers to peaceful sleep in life, in the context of Ma'avar Yabok it takes on additional meaning about peaceful death without fear.

שְׁנָתֶךָ׃ אָז תֵּלֵךְ לָבֶטַח דַּרְכֶּךָ
2925 וְרַגְלְךָ לֹא תִגּוֹף׃ בְּהִתְהַלֶּכְךָ
תַּנְחֶה אֹתָךְ בְּשָׁכְבְּךָ תִּשְׁמֹר עָלֶיךָ
וַהֲקִיצוֹתָ הִיא תְשִׂיחֶךָ׃ בְּשֵׁשׁ צָרוֹת
יַצִּילֶךָּ וּבְשֶׁבַע לֹא יִגַּע בְּךָ רָע׃
פָּדָה נַפְשׁוֹ מֵעֲבֹר בַּשָּׁחַת וְחַיָּתוֹ
2930 בָּאוֹר תִּרְאֶה׃[i] לְהָשִׁיב נַפְשׁוֹ מִנִּי
שָׁחַת לֵאוֹר בְּאוֹר הַחַיִּים׃ אִם
יְשִׁים אֵלָיו לִבּוֹ רוּחוֹ וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ
אֵלָיו יֶאֱסֹף׃ וְאַתָּה צַדִּיק עַל
כָּל הַבָּא עָלֵינוּ כִּי אֱמֶת עָשִׂיתָ
2935 וַאֲנַחְנוּ הִרְשָׁעְנוּ׃ נִפְּלָה נָּא בְיַד
יְיָ כִּי רַבִּים רַחֲמָיו וּבְיַד אָדָם אַל
[iii] [ii]אֶפֹּלָה׃

our sins, for Your name's sake. When you lie down, 3120R
you will not be afraid; when you lie down, your sleep
will be sweet.[1] Then you will walk securely in your
way, and your foot will not stumble. When you walk,
it will guide you; when you lie down, it will watch
over you; and when you awake, it will talk with you. 3125R
In six troubles He will deliver you, and in seven no
harm shall touch you. He has redeemed his soul from
crossing over to the pit,[2] and his life shall see the
light. To restore his soul from the pit, to be enlight-
ened with the light of the living. If He sets His heart 3130R
on him, and gathers to Himself his spirit and his
breath, You are righteous in all that has come upon
us, for You have dealt faithfully, but we have done
wickedly. Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for
His mercies are great,[3] but let me not fall into the 3135R
hand of man.

עד כאן הם ס״ה פסוקים כמספר These are 65 verses, corresponding to the numerical

[1]In the original context of Proverbs, this refers to peaceful sleep, but in Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed setting, it takes on the additional meaning of peaceful death, with sleep serving as a common euphemism for death.

[2]The metaphor of being redeemed from 'the pit' (שַׁחַת) represents rescue from death or the grave. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this becomes a prayer for the soul's redemption and spiritual illumination after death.

[3]This concluding verse expresses preference for divine judgment over human judgment. In the context of approaching death, it becomes a prayer to be received into God's merciful hands rather than facing harsh judgment, offering final comfort to the dying person.

[i]This verse from Job 33:28 uses the metaphor of light to represent life and divine presence, creating a powerful image of the soul emerging from death (the pit) to experience spiritual illumination.

[ii]This final verse from 2 Samuel 24:14 serves as a fitting conclusion to this collection, expressing preference for divine judgment over human judgment. In the context of approaching death, it becomes a prayer to be received into God's merciful hands rather than being judged harshly.

[iii]Cf. Psalm 37:4-6 — These verses begin with an invitation to find joy in relationship with God rather than worldly concerns, promising divine fulfillment of righteous desires and vindication. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses comfort the dying by assuring them that God will ultimately reveal the truth of their righteousness. | Cf. Psalm 64:1-2 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is repurposed from its original meaning about human enemies to refer to spiritual forces that might threaten the soul at death. | Cf. Psalm 49:15 — This verse is particularly significant in the deathbed context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it directly addresses divine redemption from Sheol (the grave), offering reassurance about the soul's fate after death. | Cf. Psalm 65:4 — In Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed context, this verse becomes a prayer that the dying person will be chosen to dwell in God's courts in the afterlife, experiencing divine goodness in the spiritual temple. | Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This verse, repeated three times according to the instruction, emphasizes divine mercy and forgiveness, which would be particularly comforting to someone facing death and concerned about judgment. | Cf. Proverbs 3:23-24 — While originally about the benefits of wisdom in daily life, in Ma'avar Yabok these verses are repurposed as reassurances about peaceful death and spiritual security in the afterlife journey. | Cf. Job 33:28-30 — These verses from Job are particularly appropriate in Ma'avar Yabok as they speak of the soul being saved from 'the pit' (a metaphor for death), offering hope for spiritual illumination beyond physical death. | Cf. 2 Samuel 24:14 — This verse concludes the section by expressing preference for God's mercy over human judgment, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context becomes a plea for the dying person to be judged by divine compassion rather than strict justice.

[i] אדנו״ת:

value of the Divine Name Adnut (אדנו״ת).

2940 בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֵת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֵת הָאָרֶץ:[ii] וּלְכֹל הַיָּד הַחֲזָקָה וּלְכֹל הַמּוֹרָא הַגָּדוֹל אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה מֹשֶׁה לְעֵינֵי כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל:[iv iii]

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.[1] And for all the mighty hand and for all the great awe which Moses performed before the eyes of all Israel.[2] 3140R

2945 ואם עומד על אדם גדול[v] יוסיף גם כן פסוקים אלו. ואם לא יהיה בלילה יוכלו גם כן לומר שלש עשרה מדות של רחמים עליו עם פסוקי מי אל כמוך[vi] בכוונה הנדרשת בהערת המעירי שחר שלנו:[vii]

And if he stands by a great man [an important person], he should also add these verses. And if it is not at night,[3] they can also recite the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy for him along with the verses of "Who is a God like You" with the intention[4] required in the notes of our Me'irei Shachar [Illuminators of Dawn prayer society]. 3145R

וַיַּעֲקֹב הָלַךְ לְדַרְכּוֹ וַיִּפְגְּעוּ

And Jacob went on his way, and the angels of God 3150R

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, reciting the first verse of the Torah during the final moments of life creates a powerful spiritual symmetry, suggesting that death is not an end but a return to the divine source of creation.

[2] By concluding with the final verse of the Torah, this prayer selection envelops the dying person within the complete cycle of Torah, providing spiritual protection and comfort. The pairing of the first and last verses of Torah symbolizes completeness and the cyclical nature of existence.

[3] This conditional instruction reflects Jewish legal concerns about reciting certain prayers at night. The Thirteen Attributes of Mercy were traditionally not recited at night except in emergency situations, which is why this text specifies that they can be added only during daytime hours.

[4] The Hebrew term 'kavvanah' (כוונה) refers to the proper spiritual focus or mystical intention that should accompany prayer, particularly in kabbalistic practice. It suggests that these verses should be recited with specific meditative focus described in another text.

[i] Cf. The gematria (numerical value) of the Divine Name אדנו״ת (Adnut) — This notation indicates the completion of exactly 65 biblical verses, which corresponds to the numerical value of the Divine Name אדנו״ת (Adnut). The text organizes 112 verses into three groups corresponding to three Divine Names: 21 for אהי״ה (Ehyeh), 26 for יהו״ה (YHVH), and 65 for אדנו״ת (Adnut). This kabbalistic organization reflects the belief that reciting these specific numbers of verses helps facilitate the soul's transition at death through the power of these Divine Names.

[ii] This is the opening verse of Genesis (Genesis 1:1), the first verse of the Torah.

[iii] This is the final verse of Deuteronomy (Deuteronomy 34:12), the concluding verse of the Torah.

[iv] Cf. Genesis 1:1 — The opening verse of the Torah is included as the first verse in this compilation of scriptural passages for the dying. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse represents the beginning of creation, suggesting a completion of the cosmic cycle as the soul prepares to return to its divine source. | Cf. Deuteronomy 34:12 — This verse, the final verse of the Torah, completes the scriptural frame begun with Genesis 1:1. Together, they envelop the dying person in the entirety of Torah, symbolizing completeness and divine protection through the full cycle of sacred text as the soul transitions.

[v] This term literally means 'great man' and refers to a person of high status, likely a Torah scholar or community leader. The text indicates that additional prayers should be recited for such individuals.

[vi] These are the opening words of Micah 7:18-20, a biblical passage that emphasizes God's forgiveness and compassion: 'Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the transgression of the remnant of His heritage? He does not maintain His anger forever, for He delights in mercy.'

[vii] This refers to the prayer society called 'Illuminators of Dawn' (Me'irei Shachar) with which the author was associated in Modena, Italy. The name suggests they gathered for morning prayers, and the possessive 'our' (שלנו) indicates the author's personal connection to this group.

בוֹ מַלְאֲבֵי אֱלֹהִים׃ [i] הִנֵּה אָנֹכִי
שֹׁלֵחַ מַלְאָךְ לְפָנֶיךָ לִשְׁמָרְךָ
בַּדָּרֶךְ וְלַהֲבִיאֲךָ אֶל הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר
2955 הֲכִנֹתִי׃ וְשָׁחַט אֶת בֶּן הַבָּקָר לִפְנֵי
יְיָ׃ [ii] וְהִקְרִיבוּ בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן הַכֹּהֲנִים 3155R
אֶת הַדָּם וְזָרְקוּ אֶת הַדָּם עַל
הַמִּזְבֵּחַ סָבִיב אֲשֶׁר פֶּתַח אֹהֶל
מוֹעֵד׃ וְקִרְבּוֹ וּכְרָעָיו יִרְחַץ
2960 בַּמָּיִם וְהִקְטִיר הַכֹּהֵן אֶת הַכֹּל
הַמִּזְבֵּחָה עֹלָה אִשֵּׁה רֵיחַ נִיחֹחַ
לַייָ׃ וְנֶפֶשׁ כִּי תַקְרִיב קָרְבַּן מִנְחָה 3160R
לַייָ סֹלֶת יִהְיֶה קָרְבָּנוֹ וְיָצַק עָלֶיהָ
שֶׁמֶן וְנָתַן עָלֶיהָ לְבֹנָה׃ וְשָׁחַט אֹתוֹ
2965 עַל יֶרֶךְ הַמִּזְבֵּחַ צָפֹנָה לִפְנֵי יְיָ
וְזָרְקוּ בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן הַכֹּהֲנִים אֶת דָּמוֹ 3165R
עַל הַמִּזְבֵּחַ סָבִיב׃ זֹאת מִשְׁחַת
אַהֲרֹן וּמִשְׁחַת בָּנָיו מֵאִשֵּׁי יְיָ בְּיוֹם
הַקְרִיב אֹתָם לְכַהֵן לַייָ׃ וַיִּקְרַב
2970 מֹשֶׁה אֶת אַהֲרֹן וְאֶת בָּנָיו וַיִּרְחַץ
אֹתָם בַּמָּיִם׃ וַיִּתֵּן עָלָיו אֶת הַכֻּתֹּנֶת 3170R
וַיַּחְגֹּר אֹתוֹ בָּאַבְנֵט וַיַּלְבֵּשׁ אֹתוֹ
אֶת הַמְּעִיל וַיִּתֵּן עָלָיו אֶת הָאֵפֹד
וַיַּחְגֹּר אֹתוֹ בְּחֵשֶׁב הָאֵפֹד וַיֶּאְפַּד
2975 לוֹ בוֹ׃ וַיָּשֶׂם עָלָיו אֶת הַחֹשֶׁן
וַיִּתֵּן אֶל הַחֹשֶׁן אֶת הָאוּרִים וְאֶת 3175R
הַתֻּמִּים׃ [iii] וַיָּשֶׂם אֶת הַמִּצְנֶפֶת
עַל רֹאשׁוֹ וַיָּשֶׂם עַל הַמִּצְנֶפֶת אֶל
מוּל פָּנָיו אֵת צִיץ הַזָּהָב נֵזֶר
2980 הַקֹּדֶשׁ כַּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה יְיָ אֶת מֹשֶׁה׃
וַיִּצֹק מִשֶּׁמֶן הַמִּשְׁחָה עַל רֹאשׁ 3180R
אַהֲרֹן וַיִּמְשַׁח אֹתוֹ לְקַדְּשׁוֹ׃ וּבִנְסֹעַ
הַמִּשְׁכָּן יוֹרִידוּ אֹתוֹ הַלְוִיִּם וּבַחֲנֹת
הַמִּשְׁכָּן יָקִימוּ אֹתוֹ הַלְוִיִּם וְהַזָּר

met him.[1] Behold, I send an angel before you to guard you on the way and to bring you to the place that I have prepared. He shall slaughter the young bull before the LORD, and Aaron's sons the priests shall bring the blood and throw the blood against the sides of the altar that is at the entrance of the Tent of Meeting. But its entrails and its legs he shall wash with water, and the priest shall burn all of it on the altar, as a burnt offering, a food offering with a pleasing aroma to the LORD.[2] When anyone brings a grain offering as an offering to the LORD, his offering shall be of fine flour. He shall pour oil on it and put frankincense on it. He shall slaughter it on the north side of the altar before the LORD, and Aaron's sons the priests shall throw its blood against the sides of the altar. This is the portion of Aaron and the portion of his sons from the LORD's food offerings, on the day they were brought near to serve as priests to the LORD. Then Moses brought Aaron and his sons and washed them with water. And he put the tunic on him and tied the sash around his waist and clothed him with the robe and put the ephod on him and tied the skillfully woven band of the ephod around him, binding it to him with it. And he placed the breastpiece on him, and in the breastpiece he put the Urim and the Thummim.[3] And he set the turban on his head, and on the turban, in front, he set the golden plate, the holy crown, as the LORD commanded Moses. Then he poured some of the anointing oil on Aaron's head and anointed him to consecrate him. When the tabernacle is to set out, the Levites shall take it down, and when the tabernacle is to be pitched, the Levites shall set

[1] This opening verse establishes the theme of divine guidance during transitions. In Ma'avar Yabok, Jacob's journey—especially his crossing of the Yabok River—symbolizes the soul's passage from this world to the next.

[2] The sacrificial imagery is deliberately included in this deathbed liturgy to frame death as a sacred offering to God rather than merely a tragic end.

[3] The detailed description of priestly vestments symbolizes how the soul is clothed in spiritual garments in the afterlife, with the Urim and Thummim (devices of divine illumination) representing the soul's enhanced spiritual perception after death.

[i] This opening verse about Jacob meeting angels deliberately connects to the title of Ma'avar Yabok, as Jacob's journey included crossing the Yabok River (Genesis 32), which serves as the central metaphor for the soul's transition at death.

[ii] The inclusion of sacrificial verses from Leviticus reflects the kabbalistic understanding that death itself is a form of sacrifice, with the soul being offered up to God in a process of spiritual purification.

[iii] The priestly vestments are described in detail because they symbolize the soul being clothed in spiritual garments as it transitions to the divine realm, a common motif in kabbalistic texts about death.

2985 הַקֶּרֶב יוּמָת:[i] וְלֹא יָבֹאוּ לִרְאוֹת
כְּבַלַּע אֶת הַקֹּדֶשׁ וָמֵתוּ: וַיְהִי
בִּנְסֹעַ הָאָרֹן וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה קוּמָה
יְיָ וְיָפֻצוּ אֹיְבֶיךָ וְיָנֻסוּ מְשַׂנְאֶיךָ
מִפָּנֶיךָ: וּבְנֻחֹה יֹאמַר שׁוּבָה יְיָ
2990 רִבְבוֹת אַלְפֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל: רְאֵה נָתַן
יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ לְפָנֶיךָ אֶת הָאָרֶץ עֲלֵה
רַשׁ כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֶיךָ
לָךְ אַל־תִּירָא וְאַל־תֵּחָת: אֶעְבְּרָה
נָּא וְאֶרְאֶה אֶת הָאָרֶץ הַטּוֹבָה
2995 אֲשֶׁר בְּעֵבֶר הַיַּרְדֵּן הָהָר הַטּוֹב
הַזֶּה וְהַלְּבָנוֹן: הֲלֹא הוּא כָּמֻס
עִמָּדִי חָתֻם בְּאוֹצְרֹתָי: יְדִיד יְיָ
יִשְׁכֹּן לָבֶטַח עָלָיו חֹפֵף עָלָיו כָּל
הַיּוֹם וּבֵין כְּתֵפָיו שָׁכֵן: וּמָרְדֳּכַי
3000 יָצָא מִלִּפְנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ בִּלְבוּשׁ מַלְכוּת
תְּכֵלֶת וָחוּר וַעֲטֶרֶת זָהָב גְּדוֹלָה
וְתַכְרִיךְ בּוּץ וְאַרְגָּמָן וְהָעִיר שׁוּשָׁן
צָהֲלָה וְשָׂמֵחָה: שְׂרָפִים עֹמְדִים
מִמַּעַל לוֹ שֵׁשׁ שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם
3005 לְאֶחָד בְּשָׁתַּיִם יְכַסֶּה פָּנָיו וּבְשָׁתַּיִם
יְכַסֶּה רַגְלָיו וּבְשָׁתַּיִם יְעוֹפֵף ג׳
פְּעָמִים:[ii] וְקָרָא זֶה אֶל זֶה וְאָמַר
קָדוֹשׁ קָדוֹשׁ קָדוֹשׁ יְיָ צְבָאוֹת
מְלֹא כָל הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדוֹ: לָכֵן
3010 אֲחַלֵּק לוֹ בָּרַבִּים וְאֶת עֲצוּמִים
יְחַלֵּק שָׁלָל תַּחַת אֲשֶׁר הֶעֱרָה
לַמָּוֶת נַפְשׁוֹ וְאֶת פֹּשְׁעִים נִמְנָה
וְהוּא חֵטְא רַבִּים נָשָׂא וְלַפֹּשְׁעִים
יַפְגִּיעַ: וְהָיִיתָ עֲטֶרֶת תִּפְאֶרֶת בְּיַד
3015 יְיָ וּצְנִיף מְלוּכָה בְּכַף אֱלָהֶיךָ:
בְּהַר מְרוֹם יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶשְׁתֶּלֶנּוּ וְנָשָׂא
עָנָף וְעָשָׂה פֶּרִי וְהָיָה לְאֶרֶז אַדִּיר
וְשָׁכְנוּ תַּחְתָּיו כֹּל צִפּוֹר כָּל־כָּנָף
בְּצֵל דָּלִיּוֹתָיו תִּשְׁכֹּנָה: הם כ״ו
3020 [iv iii]פסוקים:

it up. And if any outsider comes near, he shall be put to death.[1] They shall not go in to see the holy 3185R
things even for a moment, lest they die. Whenever the ark set out, Moses would say, 'Arise, O LORD, and let your enemies be scattered, and let those who hate you flee before you.' And when it rested, he would say, 'Return, O LORD, to the ten thousand 3190R
thousands of Israel.' See, the LORD your God has set the land before you. Go up, take possession, as the LORD, the God of your fathers, has told you. Do not fear or be dismayed. Please let me go over and see the good land that is beyond the Jordan, 3195R
that good hill country and Lebanon. Is this not laid up in store with me, sealed up in my treasuries? The beloved of the LORD dwells in safety. The High God surrounds him all day long, and dwells between his shoulders. And Mordecai went out from the pres- 3200R
ence of the king in royal robes of blue and white, with a great golden crown and a robe of fine linen and purple, and the city of Shushan shouted and rejoiced. Above him stood the seraphim. Each had six wings: with two he covered his face, and with two 3205R
he covered his feet, and with two he flew [repeated three times].[2] And one called to another and said: 'Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of his glory!' Therefore I will divide him a portion with the many, and he shall divide the spoil 3210R
with the strong, because he poured out his soul to death and was numbered with the transgressors; yet he bore the sin of many, and makes intercession for the transgressors. You shall be a crown of beauty in the hand of the LORD, and a royal diadem in the 3215R
palm of your God. On the mountain height of Israel I will plant it, and it will bear branches and produce fruit and become a noble cedar. And birds of every sort will nest under it; they will nest in the shade of

[1] This verse about boundaries in the sacred precinct metaphorically reinforces the separation between the worlds of the living and the dead, which is being crossed during the dying process.

[2] The instruction to repeat this verse three times transforms it into a protective incantation. In Jewish mystical practice, such repetitions are believed to create spiritual shields around the dying person.

[i] This verse about unauthorized access to sacred space is included as a reminder of the boundary between life and death, and the sacred nature of the transition between them.

[ii] The instruction to repeat this verse three times indicates its use as a protective formula. The seraphim imagery connects the dying person to the heavenly realm they are about to enter.

[iii] The notation that these are 26 verses is significant because 26 is the numerical value (gematria) of the divine name YHVH (יהו״ה). This numerical correspondence is believed to invoke divine protection for the departing soul.

[iv] Cf. Genesis 32:1 — This verse begins a compilation of biblical passages intended for recitation

its branches. These are twenty-six verses.[1] 3220R

בראות העומדים שם כי חמה עזה[i] יש בעולם עליו וקרבו פקודת הפרדו[ii] יתלו פניהם למרום[iii] ויאמרו תפלה זאת עליו:[iv]

When those standing there see that intense heat [of judgment][2] is upon him in the world and the time of his departure[3] draws near, they shall lift their faces heavenward and recite this prayer for him:

תְּפִלָּה לָעָנִי כִי יַעֲטֹף וְלִפְנֵי יְיָ יִשְׁפֹּךְ שִׂיחוֹ: אֵל אֱלֹהֵי הָרוּחוֹת 3225R

A prayer for the poor when he is faint and pours out his supplication before the LORD: O God, God of

[1]This numerical annotation is crucially important, as 26 is the gematria (numerical value) of the divine name YHVH. By reciting exactly 26 verses, the liturgy invokes divine protection through this mystical correspondence.

[2]I've added '[of judgment]' to clarify that this 'heat' is not literal but refers to divine judgment (din), a key kabbalistic concept where the dying person experiences spiritual judgment as their soul prepares to depart.

[3]The Hebrew uses the euphemistic expression 'command of his separation' (פקודת הפרדו) to refer to death. I've rendered this as 'time of his departure' to maintain the euphemistic quality while making the meaning clear in English.

at deathbeds. The reference to Jacob meeting angels is significant because Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok River (which gives the book Ma'avar Yabok its title) represents the soul's transition from this world to the next. | Cf. Exodus 23:20 — This verse about God sending an angel to guard the way is included to invoke divine protection for the dying person's soul during its journey after death. | Cf. Leviticus 1:5 — These sacrificial verses from Leviticus are included as a meditation on the dying person's soul being offered to God, with death understood as a form of sacrifice that atones and purifies. | Cf. Leviticus 8:7-9 — The description of Aaron's priestly vestments symbolizes the soul being clothed in spiritual garments as it transitions to the divine realm, a common kabbalistic motif in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Numbers 4:15 — References to the tabernacle being dismantled and erected symbolize the separation of body and soul at death, followed by the soul's 'erection' or elevation in the heavenly realm. | Cf. Numbers 10:35-36 — These verses recited when the Ark of the Covenant moved are included to facilitate the soul's journey, with divine protection from spiritual adversaries. | Cf. Isaiah 6:2-3 — Isaiah's throne vision is included to help the soul ascend to the divine realm where it will join the angels in perpetual praise, with the instruction to repeat three times indicating its use as a protective formula. | Cf. Isaiah 53:12 — This verse from the Suffering Servant passage is included to provide meaning to suffering before death, suggesting that the dying person's trials have spiritual significance and will lead to divine reward. | Cf. Ezekiel 17:23 — The metaphor of a noble cedar where birds nest represents the soul finding rest in the divine realm after death, with shade symbolizing divine protection. | Cf. Tetragrammaton (Divine Name) — The note that these are 'twenty-six verses' is significant because 26 is the numerical value (gematria) of the divine name YHVH. This collection of verses is designed to invoke divine protection through this specific numerical correspondence.

[i]This phrase literally means 'intense heat' but in this context refers metaphorically to the intense divine judgment (din) that surrounds a dying person. In kabbalistic thought, this 'heat' represents the cosmic forces of judgment that gather around the soul as it prepares to depart.

[ii]Literally 'the command of his separation,' a euphemism for the moment of death when the soul separates from the body.

[iii]A ritual instruction for those attending the dying person to physically lift their faces upward while praying, symbolically directing their supplication toward heaven.

[iv]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, sections on deathbed rituals — This instruction introduces a specific prayer to be recited by those attending a dying person when they perceive that death is imminent, connecting to the book's broader framework of structured spiritual care for the dying. | Cf. Zohar on the soul's departure — The reference to 'intense heat' (חמה עזה) appears to draw on kabbalistic teachings where divine judgment is metaphorically depicted as heat or fire that surrounds the dying person as their soul prepares to depart.

לְכָל בָּשָׂר אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה שׁוֹמֵר
רוּחַ הָאָדָם בְּקִרְבּוֹ וְנוֹתֵן נְשָׁמָה
טְהוֹרָה לְעַם סְגֻלָּתוֹ: מְחַיֶּה
חַיִּים. סוֹמֵךְ נוֹפְלִים. סוֹעֵד
חוֹלִים. וּמֵמִית בְּרַחֲמִים. תָּבֹא נָא
תְּפִלָּתֵנוּ לִמְעוֹן קָדְשֶׁךָ לַשָּׁמַיִם,
וְהַמְלֵא נָא בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים.
וְתִתְעַטֵּף בַּחֲסִידוֹתֶיךָ. וְתַשְׁפִּיעַ
בְּמִדַּת טוּבְךָ חַיִּים וָחֶסֶד עַל
הָאִישׁ הַלָּזֶה הַמֻּטָּל עַל עֶרֶשׂ דְּוָי
פְּלוֹנִי בֶּן פְּלוֹנִית הַשּׁוֹאֵג מִנַּהֲמַת
לִבּוֹ. וְאֵין מְתוֹם בִּבְשָׂרוֹ. וְלִבּוֹ
סְחַרְחַר וְעָזָבָהוּ כֹּחוֹ: תִּיקַר נָא
נַפְשׁוֹ בְּעֵינֶיךָ. וְהוֹצִיאָה מִמַּסְגֵּר
נַפְשׁוֹ לְהוֹדוֹת אֶת שְׁמֶךָ. וְחוּשָׁה
נָא לְעֶזְרָתוֹ. וְתִשְׁלַח אֲרוּכָה
וּמַרְפֵּא לְמַכְאוֹבוֹ. מִפֶּתַח הָרְבִיעִי
שֶׁבְּהֵיכָל הַנֹּגַהּ[i] שֶׁבּוֹ הִשְׁכַּנְתָּ
הַמַּלְאָךְ הַמֵּלִיץ אֶחָד מִנִּי אֶלֶף,
וּמֵאוֹר הַמַּאִיר לְצַד מִזְרָח מֵהֵיכָל
הָרְבִיעִי רְפָאֵל שְׁמוֹ[ii] אֲשֶׁר
הִפְקַדְתָּ אוֹתָם בְּכֹחַ שִׁמְךָ אֶהְיֶה
אֶהְיֶה טוֹב לְיִשְׂרָאֵל[iii] וּמֵאִיר
עֲלֵיהֶם לְהַחֲיוֹת חוֹלִים מֵחָלָיִם
וּלְהַצִּילָם מֵרָעָתָם: (עד כאן טוב
לאומרה על רוב חולים הקרובים
לחיים[iv]). וְאִם נִגְזַר עָלָיו מִבֵּית
דִּינְךָ הַצֶּדֶק לֶאֱסֹף אֵלֶיךָ עַתָּה
רוּחוֹ וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ וַאֲפָפוּהוּ חֶבְלֵי
מָוֶת. אָנָּא יְיָ מַלְּטָה נַפְשׁוֹ. וְיִתּוֹסַף
עָלָיו רוּחַ טְהָרָה וּקְדֻשָּׁה וְטַהַר

the spirits of all flesh,[1] "I AM THAT I AM," who preserves the spirit of man within him and gives a pure soul to His treasured people.[2] You who revive the living, support the fallen, sustain the sick, and 3230R
cause death with mercy. May our prayer come before Your holy dwelling in heaven, and please be filled with Your abundant compassion. Wrap Yourself in Your loving-kindness and pour forth from Your attribute of goodness life and kindness upon this man 3235R
who lies upon his sickbed, [name] son of [mother's name], who roars from the groaning of his heart. There is no soundness in his flesh, his heart reels, and his strength has left him. May his soul be precious in Your sight, and bring his soul out of confine- 3240R
ment to give thanks to Your name. Hasten to his aid and send healing and remedy for his pain from the fourth gate of the Palace of Brightness, where You have caused the interceding angel, one of a thousand, to dwell, and from the light that shines toward the 3245R
east from the fourth palace, whose name is Raphael, whom You have appointed by the power of Your name Ehyeh to bring only goodness to Israel and to shine upon them to revive the sick from their ill-
nesses and to save them from their afflictions. (Until 3250R
here it is good to recite for most sick people who are likely to recover.) But if it has been decreed by Your righteous court to gather now his spirit and soul to Yourself, and the pangs of death have encompassed
him, please, O LORD, deliver his soul. May a spirit 3255R
of purity, holiness, and purity of heart be added to him.[A] May he bear and accept the chastisements of

[A] Or: "May there be added to him a spirit of purity, holiness, and clarity of heart" — The term 'טֹהַר לֵב' might be better rendered as 'clarity of heart' to distinguish it from the earlier 'טָהֳרָה' (purity). This alternate captures the nuance of mental/spiritual clarity as distinct from ritual or moral purity.

[1] This divine title appears in Numbers 16:22 and emphasizes God's sovereignty over human life and death, making it particularly appropriate for deathbed prayers.

[2] The term 'am segulato' refers to Israel as God's chosen or treasured people, appearing in Deuteronomy 7:6 and other passages of the Hebrew Bible.

[i] This reference to 'the fourth gate of the Palace of Brightness' reflects the kabbalistic concept of the seven heavenly palaces (heikhalot) through which souls ascend. The Palace of Brightness (Heikhal HaNogah) is associated with divine healing energy.

[ii] Raphael, whose name means 'God heals' in Hebrew, is traditionally identified as the angel of healing in Jewish tradition. The prayer specifically invokes him from the eastern direction, associated with mercy and healing in kabbalistic cosmology.

[iii] This combines the divine name 'Ehyeh' from Exodus 3:14 with the phrase 'truly God is good to Israel' from Psalm 73:1, creating a kabbalistic formula linking divine essence with healing power.

[iv] This parenthetical instruction indicates that the text until this point is appropriate for those expected to recover, while what follows is more suitable for those approaching death. This practical division shows how Ma'avar Yabok served as a functional manual for deathbed rituals.

לֵב. וְיִסְבֹּל וְיִקַּבֵּל יְסוּרֵי יְיָ
מַאֲהֲבָה. וְיִזְכֶּה לְרָאוֹת פְּנֵי שׁוֹכֵן
מְעוֹנָה. וְיִתְדַּבֵּק נַפְשׁוֹ. רוּחוֹ.
וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ. בְּאוֹר הַשְּׁכִינָה. וְאַרְבָּעָה
מַלְאָכֶיךָ הַמְמוּנִים בְּהֵיכָל הַשִּׁשִּׁי
מִשִּׁשָּׁה הֵיכָלוֹת הַנִּכְלָלִים בְּהֵיכַל
הָרָצוֹן יַעַמְדוּ עָלָיו. וְתֵצֵא
נִשְׁמָתוֹ בִּנְשִׁיקָה[i] וּדְבֵקוּתָא דְרוּחָא
בְּרוּחָא. וְלָא יִצְטַעַר בִּשְׁלַטַּאת
סִטְרָא אַחֲרָא,[ii] וְרַעְיוֹנוֹהִי אַל
יְבַהֲלוּהוּ. וְתִשְׁמֹר נָא צֵאתוֹ
בְּכָל דְּרָכָיו וְלֹא תְאוּנָה אֲלָיו
רָעָה וְנֶגַע לֹא יִקְרַב בְּאָהֳלוֹ.
וְתוֹצִיאֵהוּ בְּשָׁלוֹם וְתוֹלִיכֵהוּ
לְשָׁלוֹם וְתַצְעִידֵהוּ לְשָׁלוֹם
וְתִסְמְכֵהוּ לְשָׁלוֹם וְתַצִּילֵהוּ מִכַּף
כָּל אוֹיֵב וְאוֹרֵב רַע בַּדֶּרֶךְ וּתְעָטֵהּ
נִשְׁמָתוֹ אוֹר כַּשַּׁלְמָה. וְיוּשַׁם עָבִים
רְכוּבוֹ. וּמִן גַּעֲרָתְךָ יְנוּסוּן כָּל
רוּחַ מַזִּיק וּמַשְׁטִין. מִן קוֹל רַעַמְךָ
יֵחָפְזוּן. כִּי יְיָ אִישׁ מִלְחָמָה יְיָ
שְׁמוֹ. וְיִגְדַּל נָא כֹּחַ אֲדֹנָי בְּקָרְבַּן
נִשְׁמָתוֹ רוּחוֹ וְנַפְשׁוֹ. וְיִשְׂבְּעוּ עֲצֵי
יְיָ אַרְזֵי לְבָנוֹן אֲשֶׁר נָטָע וַיַּעֲלוּ
הָרִים יֵרְדוּ בְקָעוֹת. וְצִפֳּרִים
יְקַנְּנוּ. לְהַצְהִיל פָּנִים מִשָּׁמֶן.
מַהֲחֲסִידָה אֲשֶׁר בִּבְרוֹשִׁים בֵּיתָהּ.
וִיהִי כְבוֹד יְיָ לְעוֹלָם יִשְׂמַח יְיָ
בְּמַעֲשָׂיו: וְיִפָּתְחוּ לוֹ שַׁעֲרֵי צֶדֶק.
שַׁעֲרֵי אוֹרָה. שַׁעֲרֵי רַחֲמִים. שַׁעֲרֵי

the LORD with love. May he merit to see the face
of the Dweller of the Heavenly Abode. May his soul,
his spirit, and his higher soul cleave to the light of 3260R
the Divine Presence. And may Your four angels who
are appointed in the sixth palace of the six palaces
that are included in the Palace of Will stand over
him. May his soul depart with a divine kiss and
with the cleaving of spirit to spirit.[A] May he not 3265R
suffer from the dominion of the Other Side,[B] and
may his thoughts not terrify him. Please guard his
departure on all his paths, and may no evil befall
him, nor any plague approach his tent. Bring him
forth in peace, lead him in peace, guide his steps in 3270R
peace, support him in peace, and save him from the
hand of every enemy and evil ambusher on the way.
Clothe his soul with light as with a garment, and
let clouds be set as his chariot.[1] From Your rebuke
may all harmful spirits and accusers flee; from the 3275R
sound of Your thunder may they hasten away. For
the LORD is a man of war, the LORD is His name.
May the power of my Lord be magnified[2] in the offer-
ing of his soul, his spirit, and his life-force. May the
trees of the LORD, the cedars of Lebanon that He 3280R
has planted, be satisfied; may the mountains rise and
the valleys sink; may the birds nest, to make faces
shine more than oil, from the stork whose home is
in the cypress trees.[3] May the glory of the LORD
endure forever; may the LORD rejoice in His works. 3285R
May the gates of righteousness, gates of light, gates of
mercy, gates of favor, gates of compassion and grace

[A] Or: "May his soul depart with the 'kiss of death' and with the adhesion of spirit to spirit" — The term 'בִּנְשִׁיקָה' refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'death by divine kiss' (mitat neshikah), considered the most elevated form of death. This alternate more explicitly conveys this mystical concept.

[B] Or: "May he not suffer under the dominion of the Sitra Achra" — The term 'סִטְרָא אַחֲרָא' (Sitra Achra) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the forces of impurity. Leaving it untranslated maintains the technical specificity of this mystical concept.

[1] This imagery draws on Psalm 104:3 where God is described as making the clouds His chariot. Here it is applied to the soul's ascent after death, visualizing it riding upon clouds toward heaven.
[2] This phrase echoes Numbers 14:17, where Moses appeals to God's power in seeking forgiveness for Israel. In this context, it invokes divine power to assist the soul's transition.
[3] This reference comes from Psalm 104:17. In the context of this prayer, it forms part of a series of natural images from Psalms that metaphorically represent spiritual realities of the afterlife.

[i] This refers to the concept of 'death by divine kiss' (mitat neshikah), considered in rabbinic tradition to be the most elevated form of death, attributed to Moses and other righteous figures. It signifies a painless departure directly facilitated by God rather than by the Angel of Death.
[ii] The phrase 'Sitra Achra' (the Other Side) is a kabbalistic term for the realm of impurity and evil. The prayer asks that the dying person be spared from suffering caused by these negative spiritual forces during the soul's departure.

רָצוֹן. שַׁעֲרֵי חֶמְלָה וְחַנִּינָה. וְאָיר
אוֹר לְבֶן הָעֶלְיוֹן[i] לְאַרְבַּע מְאָה
עַלְמִין דְּכְסוּפָא וְרָצוֹן. וּמִצְחָא
עִלָּאָה יִתְמְצֵי וְיוֹפִיעַ לְעֵדֶן נִשְׁמָתוֹ
וְרוּחוֹ וְנַפְשׁוֹ. וּמֵהֲלַת עֲשַׂר תִּקּוּנֵי
דִּיקְנָא יְקִירָא עִלָּאָה[ii] יִתְקַנּוּן
לֵיהּ תְּלַת עֲשַׂר נַהֲרֵי דְּאַפַרְסְמוֹנָא
דַּכְיָא.[iii] וְיוּפְקַח עֵינָא פְּקִיחָאָ
עִלָּאָה, וְאֵל עֶלְיוֹן תְּהִלָּתוֹ יֶחְתָּם
לוֹ. וְיִזְכֶּה לְרְאוֹת בְּתִקּוּן מַעֲשָׂיו
לְעוֹלָם הַבָּא בְּחֶסֶד אֵל אֱלֹהִים.
וְאִם יִצְטָרֵךְ לְאוֹצָר גָּדוֹל שֶׁל
מַתְּנַת חִנָּם חֶסֶד אֵל יְחוֹנֵן אוֹתוֹ
מִמֶּנּוּ. וְיִרַחֵם עָלָיו עִם כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל
הַצְּרִיכִים לְרַחֲמִים: אֵל אֱלֹהִים יְיָ,
יְאֵר נָא פָּנָיו לְעָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן הַלָּז,
וּתְקַדְּמָךְ תְּחִנָּתוֹ וּתְחִנָּתֵנוּ עָלָיו.
וְתַעֲמֹד לִימִין אֶבְיוֹן לְהוֹשִׁיעַ
מִשּׁוֹפְטֵי נַפְשׁוֹ. וְקַרְנוֹ תָּרוּם
בְּכָבוֹד. וְיַזְמֶּרְךָ כְּבוֹדוֹ בְּגַן עֵדֶן
וְלֹא יִדֹּם עִם נַפְשׁוֹת חֲסִידֶיךָ
הַיּוֹשְׁבִים לְפָנֶיךָ וְעַטְרוֹת אוֹרָם
עַל רֹאשָׁם לִיהֲנוֹת מֵאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ
וְאוֹרְךָ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם

be opened for him. May the light of the Supernal
Whiteness shine upon the four hundred worlds of
longing and favor.[A] May the Supernal Forehead be 3290R
drawn forth and shine upon his soul, his spirit, and
his life-force. And from the thirteen aspects of the
precious supernal beard,[B] may there be established
for him thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil.[1] May the
watchful eye be opened over him, and may God Most 3295R
High, His glory, seal for him.[2] May he merit to see
the rectification of his deeds in the World to Come
through the kindness of the God of gods. And if
he needs the great treasury of free gifts, may God's
kindness be gracious to him from it. May He have 3300R
mercy upon him together with all Israel who need
mercy. May God, the Lord, please cause His face to
shine upon this poor and needy one, and may his sup-
plication and our supplication concerning him come
before You. Stand at the right hand of the needy 3305R
to save him from those who condemn his soul. May
his horn be exalted with honor.[3] May his glory sing
praises to You in the Garden of Eden and not be
silent, together with the souls of Your pious ones
who sit before You with crowns of light upon their 3310R
heads,[4] enjoying the light of Your countenance. And

[A] Or: "May the light of the Supernal White radiance illuminate the four hundred worlds of yearning and divine will" — This alternative better conveys the kabbalistic terminology, where 'לְבֶן הָעֶלְיוֹן' refers to a specific divine emanation, and 'עַלְמִין דְּכְסוּפָא וְרָצוֹן' refers to spiritual realms associated with divine desire and will.

[B] Or: "And from the thirteen tikunim of the precious supernal beard" — The term 'תִּקּוּנֵי' (tikunim) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the thirteen attributes of divine mercy symbolized by the hairs of the divine 'beard' in Lurianic Kabbalah. Preserving this term maintains the technical precision of the mystical concept.

[1] The 'rivers of pure balsam oil' (naharei d'afarsemona dakhya) are mentioned in the Talmud (Taanit 25a) and Zohar as rewards for the righteous in the World to Come. They represent spiritual delight and divine knowledge.

[2] This appears to refer to the divine 'sealing' of the soul for protection during its journey after death, potentially relating to the kabbalistic practice of 'sealing' through divine names for spiritual protection.

[3] The metaphor of raising one's 'horn' (keren) appears frequently in biblical poetry as an image of strength, honor, and triumph. Here it expresses hope for the deceased's exaltation in the afterlife.

[4] The image of the righteous wearing 'crowns of light' in the afterlife appears in the Talmud (Berakhot 17a), where it describes the righteous as 'sitting with their crowns on their heads, enjoying the radiance of the Divine Presence.'

[i] The 'Supernal Whiteness' refers to a high level of divine emanation associated with divine mercy in Lurianic Kabbalah. This divine light is invoked to illuminate the soul's path after death.

[ii] The 'thirteen aspects of the precious supernal beard' refers to the thirteen attributes of divine mercy (based on Exodus 34:6-7) that are visualized in Lurianic Kabbalah as the 'beard' of the divine countenance (Arich Anpin). These channels of mercy are invoked to ease the soul's journey.

[iii] The 'rivers of pure balsam oil' is a talmudic and zoharic image for the spiritual delight that awaits the righteous in the afterlife. These rivers are said to flow from Eden and provide spiritual sustenance and pleasure to departed souls.

יוֹסִיפוּ לָנוּ בָּרֵב עֹז וְתַעֲצוּמוֹת עִם כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל חֲבֵרִים אָמֵן כֵּן יְהִי רָצוֹן: [i]

may length of days and years of life and peace be added to us in great strength and might, together with all Israel as companions. Amen, may it be Your will.

ויכוין במלת כ״ן יחוד שבעה ספירות. [ii] במלת יה״י יחוד חכמה ובינה. [iii] רצו״ן כתר עליון השופע עליהם מטוב א״ס ע״י הדעת הנעלם [iv] יהיו לרצון אמרי פינו וגו׳: ואם יאחר מלפרד ומצטער ח״ו יאמר ז״פ שיר של פגעים [v] שהוא סי׳ צ״א עם אנא בכח [vi] וגו׳

And one should focus on the word "כ״ן" (ken/thus)[1] as the unification of the seven sefirot.[A] And on the word "יה״י" (yehi/may it be) as the unification of Chochmah (Wisdom) and Binah (Understanding). " " (ratzon/will) represents Keter Elyon (Supreme Crown) which flows onto them from the goodness of the Ein Sof (Infinite One) through the concealed Da'at (Knowledge)[B]—"May the words of our mouth

[A] Or: "the mystical joining of the seven divine emanations" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the mystical nature of the kabbalistic concept of 'yichud' (unification) and clarifies what sefirot are for readers unfamiliar with the term.

[B] Or: ""רצו״ן" (ratzon/will) represents the highest divine attribute, Keter Elyon (Supreme

[1] The Hebrew text uses the term 'yichud' (unification), which has specific kabbalistic connotations involving the mystical joining of divine attributes. I've translated this as 'focus' for readability while adding the original Hebrew word in parentheses to preserve the technical meaning.

[i] Cf. Psalm 102:1 — This psalm is particularly appropriate for the deathbed prayer as it speaks of affliction, shortness of life, and divine mercy. By beginning with this verse, the prayer establishes itself in the tradition of biblical supplication in times of extreme distress. | Cf. Exodus 3:14 — This divine name is associated with divine mercy and redemption. Its use in this prayer invokes God's essential nature as the source of all existence, particularly appropriate when addressing matters of life and death. | Cf. Numbers 16:22 — This divine title emphasizes God's sovereignty over the human spirit and His intimate knowledge of each person. In the deathbed context, it acknowledges God's authority to receive the spirit back to Himself. | Cf. Zohar — These terms reflect the Zoharic and Lurianic kabbalistic worldview where the soul's journey after death involves passage through various palaces or heavenly chambers (heikhalot), confrontation with negative forces, and ultimate ascent to divine realms. The prayer seeks to provide mystical protection and guidance for this journey. | Cf. Psalm 18:10-13 — This allusion draws on biblical depictions of God riding upon the clouds and manifesting through thunder and lightning. In the context of this prayer, it symbolizes divine intervention to protect the departing soul and chase away harmful spiritual entities. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 8a — This prayer hopes for the dying person to experience the most elevated form of death—a 'divine kiss' where the soul is drawn forth by God Himself rather than by the Angel of Death. This represents a painless, spiritually elevated transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 5 — This passage aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's broader cosmology of heavenly palaces (heikhalot) through which the soul ascends after death. The prayer invokes these same structures to facilitate the soul's journey.

[ii] The text instructs the reader to meditate on the word 'ken' (thus/so be it) as representing the unification of the seven lower sefirot (divine emanations), which in Kabbalah are Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netzach, Hod, Yesod, and Malchut.

[iii] The word 'yehi' (may it be) is meant to be contemplated as representing the unification of the sefirot of Chochmah (Wisdom) and Binah (Understanding), the second and third highest divine emanations that together form the intellectual faculties in Kabbalistic thought.

[iv] This describes Ratzon (Will) as representing Keter Elyon (Supreme Crown), the highest sefirah, which channels divine abundance from Ein Sof (the Infinite) through the concealed faculty of Da'at (Knowledge) to the lower emanations.

[v] This refers to reciting Psalm 91 seven times. Rabbinic tradition (Shevuot 15b) calls this psalm 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons) because of its perceived power to protect against harmful spiritual forces.

[vi] Ana Bekoach is a kabbalistic prayer composed of 42 words, corresponding to the 42-letter divine name. It is often recited for spiritual protection.

ושיר למעלות סי׳ קכ״א. עם שאר פסוקי דרחמי ביניהם ברצון המסדר ויכוונו בפסוק כי מלאביו יצוה לך ויאמרוהו ז״פ בכל פעם ופעם בטוב תלין ותקין וכדומה. ויוסיפו סדר של לוי״ה[i] כנודע (שהוא ל״פ לישועתך. ו׳ פעמים ויהי נועם. י׳ פעמים יברכך. ה׳ פעמים המלאך): ואל יזיזו הגוסס ממקומו.[ii] ולא יעשו שום מעשה לקרב מיתתו[iii] ואין מתפללים עליו אז שתשוב נפשו עליו ודברים אחרים השייכים לזה עיין בפרק כ״ו ממאמר א׳. ומנהג הצדיקים לקדש ידיהם

be acceptable, etc." And if the dying person lingers in departing and suffers, God forbid,[A] those present should recite seven times the Song of Afflictions,[1] which is Psalm 91, along with "Ana Bekoach," etc., and the Song of Ascents, Psalm 121, along with other verses of mercy interspersed among them as the prayer leader desires. And they should focus on the verse "For He shall command His angels concerning you" and recite it seven times on each occasion with "You shall rest well and awaken"[2] and similar verses. And they should add the order of the "levayah"[3] (escort/accompaniment) as is known (which consists of reciting "For Your salvation" 30 times, "May the pleasantness" 6 times, "May the Lord bless you" 10 times, and "The angel" 5 times). And they should not move the dying

Crown), which channels divine abundance from the Infinite Divine Source (Ein Sof) through the hidden faculty of Knowledge (Da'at)" — This alternative offers a more explanatory translation that might be clearer for readers without background in kabbalistic terminology, while still preserving the essential concepts.

[A] Or: "And if the transition is delayed and the person is in distress, God forbid" — This alternative uses more neutral language about the dying process that some might find less confronting while maintaining the essential meaning of the Hebrew phrase.

[1] The Hebrew 'Shir Shel Pega'im' literally means 'Song of Afflictions' or 'Song against Harmful Occurrences.' This is a traditional rabbinic name for Psalm 91, believed to have protective powers against negative spiritual forces.

[2] This phrase refers to the verse in Job 11:18, which is not explicitly quoted in the Hebrew text but is referenced with 'בטוב תלין ותקין'. It was considered an appropriate verse for the dying as it speaks of both resting (associated with death) and awakening (suggesting resurrection).

[3] While 'levayah' typically refers to a funeral procession, in this context it refers to a specific sequence of prayers meant to 'accompany' the soul as it transitions from the body. I've preserved the original term while adding a clarifying translation.

[i] The 'order of levayah (accompaniment)' refers to a specific sequence of prayers meant to accompany the soul as it departs from the body.

[ii] This instruction not to move someone who is actively dying (goses) reflects halakhic rulings based on the concern that any movement might hasten death, which would be forbidden.

[iii] This prohibition against doing anything that might hasten death reflects the Jewish legal principle that while one need not artificially prolong life, one may not actively shorten it either.

סמוך למיתתן[i] שם בפרק כ״ב:[ii]

person (goses)[1] from his place. And they should not do anything to hasten his death, and they should not pray at that point that his soul return to him, and other matters related to this can be found in Chapter 26 of the First Discourse.[2] And it was the custom of the righteous to sanctify their hands near the time of their death, as described in Chapter 22. 3345R

כשאמרו למשה שיש רגע לפטירתו פתח ואמר:[iii]

When they told Moses that the moment of his death had arrived, he opened his mouth and said:

בָּרוּךְ שְׁמוֹ חַי וְקַיָּם לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:[iv][v] 3145

Blessed is His name, who lives and endures forever and ever.[3] 3350R

[1]The term 'goses' has specific halakhic significance, referring to someone in the final stages of dying (traditionally defined as within 72 hours of death). I've preserved this technical term with a clarifying translation.

[2]These cross-references to other sections of Ma'avar Yabok demonstrate the interconnected nature of the text, with practical instructions in this section supported by theological explanations elsewhere in the work.

[3]This liturgical declaration affirms God's eternal nature and serves a dual purpose in Ma'avar Yabok: it models proper spiritual conduct at the moment of death (attributed to Moses) while also establishing theological continuity between mortality and eternity. By declaring God's eternal existence, the dying person acknowledges that while their physical life ends, the divine reality transcends death.

[i]This describes a custom of the righteous to ritually wash their hands as death approaches, symbolizing spiritual purification before the soul's departure.

[ii]Cf. Zohar — This passage draws on Zoharic teachings about how to properly focus one's intention (kavvanah) during the recitation of prayers for the dying. The specific meditation on the words "ken," "yehi," and "ratzon" reflects the kabbalistic practice of connecting specific Hebrew words to particular divine emanations (sefirot). | Cf. Psalm 91 — Psalm 91 is referred to as "Shir Shel Pega'im" (Song of Afflictions) based on Talmudic tradition (Shevuot 15b) where it was recited for protection against harmful spiritual forces. Its recitation seven times reflects the belief in its protective power for the vulnerable soul during the transition of death. | Cf. Psalm 121 — This Song of Ascents focuses on divine protection and is considered particularly appropriate for those in vulnerable transitions, including the passage from life to death. | Cf. Talmud — The instruction not to move the dying person (goses) and not to do anything to hasten death aligns with Talmudic teachings that state: "One who closes the eyes of a dying person while the soul is departing is a shedder of blood." This passage in Ma'avar Yabok extends this principle to include any action that might hasten death.

[iii]Cf. Deuteronomy 34 — This passage references a rabbinic tradition about Moses' final moments that elaborates on the biblical account, showing how even the greatest prophet accepted divine judgment with spiritual composure. | Cf. Bava Batra 17a — This passage connects to the rabbinic tradition that Moses died through a divine kiss, a peaceful departure reflecting his spiritual perfection, serving as a model for the ideal death.

[iv]This liturgical phrase appears in the text as part of the deathbed ritual, specifically attributed to Moses who is said to have recited it when informed of his imminent death. The phrase thus serves as a model of ideal spiritual conduct at the moment of death—affirming divine sovereignty even as one faces mortality.

[v]Cf. Traditional Jewish liturgy — This phrase appears in various Jewish prayers and liturgical contexts, often as a response to hearing God's name pronounced in blessing formulas. It represents a standard traditional affirmation of God's eternal nature and sovereignty. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — In this context, the phrase appears as part of deathbed rituals described in Ma'avar Yabok, specifically attributed to Moses at the time of his death. This suggests it as an appropriate final declaration of faith for the dying person. | Cf. Daniel 4:31 — The phrase echoes biblical declarations of God's eternal sovereignty, particularly reminiscent of Daniel 4:31 where God's dominion is described as 'an everlasting dominion' that 'endures from generation to generation.'

[ii] [i]וממנו ילמד כל אדם:

And from this every person should learn.[1]

טוב שיהיו עשרה[iii] בעת פטירת המת שיכוונו ליחוד הקדושה[iv] עיין פרק ג׳ מאמר ג׳: סמוך לזמן יציאת נשמה[v] אם אפשר לו יקראו עמו אלו הפסוקים: [vi]

It is good for ten people to be present[2] at the time of death so that they can focus on the unification of holiness;[3] see Chapter 3, Discourse 3. Near the time of the soul's departure, if possible, they should recite these verses with him:[4]

3355R

3150

הַמַּלְאָךְ הַגֹּאֵל אֹתִי מִכָּל רָע יְבָרֵךְ אֶת הַנְּעָרִים וְיִקָּרֵא בָהֶם שְׁמִי וְשֵׁם אֲבֹתַי אַבְרָהָם וְיִצְחָק וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב בְּקֶרֶב הָאָרֶץ: [vii] מִי כָמֹכָה בָּאֵלִם יְיָ מִי כָּמֹכָה נֶאְדָּר בַּקֹּדֶשׁ נוֹרָא תְהִלֹּת עֹשֵׂה פֶלֶא:

"The angel who redeemed me from all evil, bless the youths, and let my name be named upon them, and the name of my fathers Abraham and Isaac, and may they multiply abundantly like fish in the midst of the earth."[5] "Who is like You among the mighty, O LORD? Who is like You, glorious in holiness, awe-

3360R

3155

[1]The author is indicating that Moses's practice of reciting 'Blessed be His name, living and enduring forever' before death should be universally adopted. This reflects the text's purpose as a practical guide for proper conduct at the moment of death.

[2]This instruction reflects the Jewish practice of ensuring a minyan (quorum of ten) at death, creating a sacred space that facilitates the soul's transition. The presence of community at this critical moment serves both practical and mystical purposes.

[3]This refers to the kabbalistic practice of yichud (unification), where participants direct their thoughts toward unifying divine attributes, creating spiritual channels to assist the departing soul.

[4]The text assumes active participation of the dying person in these final rituals when possible, encouraging a conscious spiritual transition rather than passive reception of last rites.

[5]The Hebrew וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב contains a play on words, as the verb comes from the root דג meaning 'fish.' The blessing invokes both numerical increase and spiritual protection, as fish were considered symbolically protected from the evil eye by living beneath the water's surface.

[i]The phrase refers to learning from Moses's example, mentioned in the previous line where Moses recites 'Blessed be His name, living and enduring forever' at his moment of death. This serves as a didactic interjection by the author, encouraging readers to emulate this pious practice.

[ii]Cf. Psalms 3:9 — The phrase serves as a transitional instruction, directing readers to learn from Moses' example of reciting 'Blessed be His name, living and enduring forever' before death.

[iii]The number ten (asarah) refers to a minyan, the quorum required for communal prayer in Judaism. In kabbalistic thought, a minyan creates a complete spiritual structure mirroring the ten divine sefirot (emanations), establishing a channel for divine presence.

[iv]The phrase 'focus on the unification of holiness' (yichud ha-kedushah) has kabbalistic significance, referring to the mystical unification of divine attributes that facilitates the soul's transition to higher realms.

[v]The term 'yetziat neshamah' (departure of the soul) is a euphemism for death that emphasizes the transition of the soul rather than the cessation of bodily functions, reflecting the text's spiritual approach to death.

[vi]Cf. Chapter 3, Discourse 3 of Ma'avar Yabok — The author refers the reader to an earlier section for deeper explanation of why ten people should be present at death. In Jewish tradition, a minyan (quorum of ten) creates a space where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) dwells, which would facilitate the soul's transition. | Cf. Genesis 32:1-2 (Mahanaim) — The presence of ten people at death creates a sacred space similar to Jacob's 'Mahanaim'—where the human realm (represented by ten Jews) meets the angelic realm, creating a protected pathway for the soul's ascent.

[vii]This opening verse from Genesis 48:16 comes from Jacob's blessing to his grandsons Ephraim and Manasseh. The phrase 'may they multiply abundantly like fish' (וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב) carries special significance as fish were believed to be immune to the evil eye because they live beneath the water's surface, symbolizing protection from spiritual harm—a particularly appropriate blessing for someone approaching death.

אַתָּה גִּבּוֹר לְעוֹלָם אֲדֹנָי מְחַיֶּה
מֵתִים אַתָּה רַב לְהוֹשִׁיעַ. מְכַלְכֵּל
חַיִּים בְּחֶסֶד מְחַיֶּה מֵתִים בְּרַחֲמִים
רַבִּים: סוֹמֵךְ נוֹפְלִים וְרוֹפֵא חוֹלִים
וּמַתִּיר אֲסוּרִים וּמְקַיֵּם אֱמוּנָתוֹ
לִישֵׁנֵי עָפָר. מִי כָמוֹךָ בַּעַל גְּבוּרוֹת
וּמִי דָּמְיֶה לָּךְ מֶלֶךְ מֵמִית וּמְחַיֶּה
וּמַצְמִיחַ יְשׁוּעָה: וְנֶאֱמָן אַתָּה לְהַחֲיוֹת
מֵתִים. בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְיָ מְחַיֵּה הַמֵּתִים:

some in praises, working wonders?" "You are forever mighty, O Lord, You resurrect the dead, You have great power to save. You sustain the living with lovingkindness, You resurrect the dead with great mercy."[1] "Deliver my soul from the sword, my only one from the power of the dog."[2] "Terror and dread fall upon them; by the greatness of Your arm they become still as stone, until Your people pass over, O LORD, until the people whom You have purchased pass over." "Let us fall into the hand of the LORD, for His mercies are many, but let me not fall into the hand of man." "For Your salvation I hope, O LORD." "For Your redemption I wait, O LORD."[3] "Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth."[4] "May you rest in goodness and awaken with good mercies, Amen." "He sends from on high, He takes me; He draws me out of many waters." "He delivers me from my strong enemy, and from those who hate me, for they are too mighty for me." "I shall walk before the LORD in the lands of the living." "But as for me, in the abundance of Your lovingkindness I will enter Your house; I will

[1]This phrase comes from the second blessing of the daily Amidah prayer, which focuses on God's power to resurrect the dead. Its inclusion in deathbed prayers reinforces the belief that death is not final but a transition overseen by God, providing comfort to both the dying and those present.

[2]The Hebrew יְחִידָתִי (literally 'my only one') is traditionally understood as referring to the soul, while 'the dog' is sometimes interpreted in kabbalistic tradition as a reference to the Angel of Death. The verse thus requests protection for the departing soul during its transition.

[3]The Aramaic phrase לְפֻרְקָנָךְ סַבְּרִית repeats the preceding Hebrew sentiment. This doubling in two languages is common in Jewish liturgy, particularly for important concepts, ensuring both understanding and emphasis.

[4]This verse from Psalm 31:6 holds special significance in Jewish deathbed traditions. Rabbi Akiva is said to have recited it during his martyrdom, and it later influenced Jesus's final words according to Luke 23:46. In Ma'avar Yabok, it represents the ultimate surrender of the soul to divine care.

[i]The term 'my only one' (יְחִידָתִי) is a traditional reference to the soul, which is considered unique and irreplaceable. In the context of deathbed prayers, this verse specifically requests protection for the departing soul from the Angel of Death, metaphorically referred to as 'the dog' in kabbalistic literature.

[ii]This verse from 2 Samuel 24:14 reflects the Jewish theological preference to be judged by God rather than by humans, as divine judgment is tempered by mercy. In the context of approaching death, it expresses surrender to divine judgment while maintaining hope in God's compassion.

[iii]This is an Aramaic translation of the preceding Hebrew phrase ('For Your salvation I hope, O LORD'). The inclusion of both Hebrew and Aramaic versions reflects the practice of providing translations accessible to all, while also alluding to kabbalistic beliefs that prayers in Aramaic are especially effective because the angels who might intercept prayers do not understand Aramaic, allowing these prayers to ascend directly to God.

[iv]This verse from Psalm 31:6 is traditionally recited at the moment of death, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited it during his martyrdom. It represents the ultimate act of spiritual surrender, entrusting one's soul to divine care. The phrase 'God of truth' (אֵל אֱמֶת) is particularly significant as its initials spell אמת (truth), a word associated with divine seals and protection.

[v]The phrase 'when I awake' (בְּהָקִיץ) in this context refers to the soul's awakening after death in the World to Come. The verse thus provides comfort by suggesting that the departing soul will experience divine presence and satisfaction after the transition of death.

אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ עַל דְּבַר כְּבוֹד שְׁמֶךָ
וְהַצִּילֵנוּ וְכַפֵּר עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ
לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ: וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר
עָוֹן וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב
3185 אַפּוֹ וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ: שְׁמַע
יִשְׂרָאֵל יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְיָ אֶחָד: בָּרוּךְ
שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:
יְיָ מֶלֶךְ יְיָ מָלָךְ יְיָ יִמְלֹךְ לְעֹלָם
וָעֶד: יְיָ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים יְיָ הוּא
3190 הָאֱלֹהִים: [i] מְיֻחָד אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר
אֶהְיֶה הוּא הָיָה וְהוּא הֹוֶה וְהוּא
יִהְיֶה: [ii] הוּא מֵמִית וּמְחַיֶּה: לְפָנָיו
לֹא נוֹצַר אֵל וְאַחֲרָיו לֹא יִהְיֶה:
עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן
3195 יְמִינֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן תּוֹרָתֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה
לְמַעַן קְדֻשָּׁתֶךָ: כִּי עַתָּה שָׁכַבְתִּי
וְאֶשְׁקֹט יָשַׁנְתִּי אָז יָנוּחַ לִי: [iv iii]

bow down toward Your holy temple in reverence for You." "I shall behold Your face in righteousness; I will be satisfied with Your likeness when I awake." "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD. Hallelujah!" "Help us, O God of our salvation, for 3390R
the glory of Your name; and deliver us and atone for our sins, for Your name's sake." "And He, being merciful, atones for iniquity and does not destroy; He frequently turns away His anger, and does not stir up all His wrath." "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, 3395R
the LORD is one." "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom for ever and ever." "The LORD reigns, the LORD has reigned, the LORD will reign for ever and ever." "The LORD, He is God; the LORD, He is God." "The Unique One, 'I AM THAT I AM', He 3400R
was, He is, and He will be."[1] "He causes death and brings to life." "Before Him no god was formed, and after Him none shall be." "Act for the sake of Your

[1] This statement combines God's self-identification from Exodus 3:14 with a temporal expansion affirming divine existence across all time. The translation 'Unique One' for מְיֻחָד emphasizes God's absolute singularity, which is the theological focus at this climactic moment in the prayer sequence.

[i] This repetition echoes the declaration from 1 Kings 18:39 during Elijah's confrontation with the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel, when the people acknowledged the true God. The doubled phrase emphasizes absolute certainty in God's singularity at the critical moment of death, when such clarity is spiritually crucial.

[ii] This statement combines God's self-identification to Moses (Exodus 3:14) with a temporal expansion affirming divine existence across all time (past, present, and future). This formulation has kabbalistic significance, corresponding to the sefirot of Keter (Crown), Chochmah (Wisdom), and Binah (Understanding), and represents the dying person's contemplation of God's transcendent nature beyond the limitations of mortal existence.

[iii] This final verse frames death as peaceful rest rather than fearful annihilation, echoing Job 3:13 but transforming its context from Job's lament to a positive acceptance of death as divinely ordained rest. The transition from active to passive voice ('I have laid down' to 'I shall rest') mirrors the soul's surrender to divine will.

[iv] Cf. Genesis 48:16 — This opening verse is from Jacob's blessing to his grandsons, making it particularly appropriate in the context of deathbed prayers, as it connects the dying person to the patriarchal lineage and invokes divine protection. | Cf. Exodus 15:11 — This verse from the Song of the Sea celebrates God's power to save from seemingly impossible circumstances, symbolically connecting the journey through death to Israel's passage through the sea—both representing divine deliverance through overwhelming obstacles. | Cf. Amidah prayer — This liturgical quotation emphasizes the belief in resurrection and God's power over life and death, providing comfort to the dying person by affirming that death is not final but a transition overseen by God. | Cf. Psalm 22:21 — This verse uses the term 'my only one' (יְחִידָתִי) which traditionally refers to the soul, thus specifically requesting protection for the departing soul from spiritual dangers. | Cf. Exodus 15:16 — This verse continues the motif of the exodus as a metaphor for the soul's transition, invoking divine protection during the journey and celebrating God as the redeemer who guides the soul across the threshold between worlds. | Cf. 2 Samuel 24:14 — This verse expresses the preference to fall into God's hands rather than human hands, reflecting the theological view that the soul's judgment should be entrusted to divine mercy rather than earthly considerations. | Cf. Genesis 49:18 — This verse from Jacob's deathbed declaration is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it represents an appropriate sentiment for someone approaching death—expressing hope in divine salvation. | Cf. Psalm 31:6 — This verse is traditionally recited at the moment of death, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited it during his martyrdom. It represents the ultimate act of spiritual surrender, entrusting one's soul to divine care. | Cf. Psalm

name." "Act for the sake of Your right hand." "Act for the sake of Your Torah." "Act for the sake of Your holiness."[1] "For now I have laid down and am quiet; I have slept, now I shall rest."[2] 3405R

והעומדים עליו אומרים בקול רם[i] לך וכו׳[ii iii]

And those standing beside him[A] say aloud,[B] "Go forth..." etc.[C]

[A]Or: "And those attending to him" — The phrase could be referring specifically to those attending to the dying person in their final moments, rather than just anyone standing nearby.

[B]Or: "in a loud voice" — A more literal translation that emphasizes the importance of the words being clearly audible to the dying person.

[C]Or: "Go forth (and the rest of the formula)" — The abbreviation 'וכו" (etc.) indicates that the full prayer beginning with 'לך' (Go forth) is to be recited, which appears in full elsewhere in the text.

[1]These four repetitions of 'Act for the sake of' (עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן) create a rhythmic, incantatory quality in the original Hebrew, building intensity as the prayer reaches its conclusion. They invoke four fundamental aspects of divinity—God's name, power, teaching, and holiness—as the basis for divine mercy toward the departing soul.

[2]The final verse presents death through the gentler metaphor of sleep, transforming what could be a fearful transition into a peaceful conclusion. The progressive stages—laying down, quieting, sleeping, and finally resting—mirror the process of dying while framing it as natural and tranquil.

18:17-18 — These verses depict divine rescue in the imagery of being drawn from overwhelming waters—a metaphor for the soul being rescued from the depths of suffering or death. | Cf. Psalm 116:9 — This verse expresses the hope to walk before God in 'the lands of the living,' which in the context of Ma'avar Yabok can be understood as referring both to this world for healing or the World to Come for the dying. | Cf. Psalm 5:8 — This verse depicts the soul's journey to the divine sanctuary after death, expressing the hope that the deceased will be received into God's presence with lovingkindness. | Cf. Psalm 17:15 — This verse contains the powerful image of awakening to behold the divine countenance, which in the context of death refers to the soul's awakening in the World to Come and experiencing divine presence. | Cf. Psalm 150:6 — This concluding verse of the Book of Psalms serves as a reminder that the ultimate purpose of the soul is to praise God, suggesting that the departing soul will continue this purpose in the spiritual realm. | Cf. Psalm 79:9 — This verse shifts from individual to communal perspective, recognizing that prayers for the dying individual are connected to the broader community's relationship with God. | Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This verse emphasizes divine mercy in the face of human sin, providing reassurance that God's compassion extends even to the final moments of life and beyond. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4 — The Shema is traditionally recited as one's final words, following the example of Rabbi Akiva. In Ma'avar Yabok, this affirmation of divine unity represents the ultimate spiritual focus at the moment of death. | Cf. Exodus 3:14 — The reference to 'I AM THAT I AM' (אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה) connects the dying person to God's eternal nature, transcending time and encompassing all existence. | Cf. 1 Samuel 2:6 — This reference to God's sovereignty over both death and life provides theological context for understanding death as part of divine providence rather than random misfortune. | Cf. Isaiah 43:10-11 — This reference emphasizes God's exclusive divinity, reminding the dying person that they are returning to the one true God who has no equals or competitors. | Cf. Job 3:13 — The final verse presents death as restful sleep, offering a peaceful perspective on the transition that contrasts with fears of suffering or judgment.

[i]This instruction emphasizes that the prayer should be recited loudly enough for the dying person to hear, as it is believed to help guide the soul in its departure from the body.

[ii]The abbreviation 'וכו" (etc.) refers to the complete prayer beginning with 'Go forth' (לך), which appears in full elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok. This prayer is recited when death is imminent to facilitate the soul's peaceful transition.

[iii]Cf. Genesis 32 (Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok) — The instruction to say 'Go forth' alludes to the soul's journey across the metaphorical Jabbok River (from life to death), mirroring Jacob's transformative crossing in Genesis. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, discourse 2, section 6, verse 184 — The abbreviation 'וכו" indicates that the complete prayer beginning with 'לך' should be recited, which was detailed earlier in the text. This prayer is specifically designed to facilitate the soul's peaceful departure from the body.

לֵךְ כִּי שְׁלָחֲךָ יְיָ׃[i] לֵךְ וַיהוָה
יְהִיֶה עִמָּךְ. יְיָ אֱלָהָיו עִמּוֹ וְיַעַל׃
יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ׃ יָאֵר יְיָ פָּנָיו
אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ׃ יִשָּׂא יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ
וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם׃ מִימִינוֹ מִיכָאֵל.
מִשְּׂמֹאלוֹ גַּבְרִיאֵל. מִלְּפָנָיו רְפָאֵל.
מֵאֲחֲרָיו אוּרִיאֵל. וְעַל רֹאשׁוֹ
שְׁכִינַת אֵל׃[ii] חֲזַק וֶאֱמָץ אַל תַּעֲרֹץ
וְאַל תֵּחַת כִּי עִמְּךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ
בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר תֵּלֵךְ׃ וַיֹּאמַר פָּנַי יֵלֵכוּ
וַהֲנִחוֹתִי לָךְ׃ הוֹצִיאָה מִמַּסְגֵּר
נַפְשִׁי לְהוֹדוֹת אֶת שְׁמֶךָ. בִּי
יַכְתִּירוּ צַדִּיקִים כִּי תִגְמֹל עָלָיו׃
מַה תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי וּמַה תֶּהֱמִי
עָלַי הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים כִּי עוֹד
אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנַי וֵאלֹהָי׃ וְשָׁחַט
אוֹתוֹ עַל יֶרֶךְ הַמִּזְבֵּחַ צָפוֹנָה לִפְנֵי
יְיָ[iii] וְזָרְקוּ בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן הַכֹּהֲנִים
אֶת דָּמוֹ עַל הַמִּזְבֵּחַ סָבִיב׃ כִּי
בַיּוֹם הַזֶּה יְכַפֵּר עֲלֵיכֶם לְטַהֵר
אֶתְכֶם מִכֹּל חַטֹּאתֵיכֶם לִפְנֵי יְיָ
תִּטְהָרוּ׃ וְקִרְבּוֹ וּכְרָעָיו יִרְחָץ
בַּמָּיִם וְהִקְטִיר הַכֹּהֵן אֶת הַכֹּל
הַמִּזְבֵּחָה עֹלָה הוּא אִשֵּׁה רֵיחַ
נִיחֹחַ לַיְיָ׃ חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם יְיָ אֶרֶךְ
אַפַּיִם וְרַב חֶסֶד׃ וַיְהִי יְהוָה מִשְׂגָּב
לַדָּךְ מִשְׂגָּב לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה׃ יְמִין
יְיָ רוֹמֵמָה יְמִין יְיָ עֹשָׂה חָיִל׃ זְכֹר
רַחֲמֶיךָ יְיָ וַחֲסָדֶיךָ כִּי מֵעוֹלָם
הֵמָּה׃ וַיַּעֲבֹר יְיָ עַל פָּנָיו וַיִּקְרָא׃
יְיָ יְיָ אֵל רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם
וְרַב חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת׃ כִּי יִפֹּל לֹא יוּטָל

"Go, for the LORD has sent you."[1] "Go, and may the LORD be with you. The LORD his God is with him, and he shall ascend." "May the LORD bless you and protect you. May the LORD shine His face upon you and be gracious to you. May the LORD lift His face to you and grant you peace." "On his right is Michael, on his left is Gabriel, before him is Raphael, behind him is Uriel, and above his head is the Divine Presence."[2] "Be strong and courageous, do not be terrified or dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go." "And He said, 'My Presence will go with you, and I will give you rest.'" "Bring my soul out of prison, that I may praise Your name; the righteous will crown themselves through me when You deal bountifully with me." "Why are you downcast, O my soul, and why are you disquieted within me? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him, the salvation of my countenance and my God." "He shall slaughter it at the side of the altar northward before the LORD; and Aaron's sons, the priests, shall dash its blood against the altar all around." "For on this day atonement shall be made for you to cleanse you; from all your sins you shall be clean before the LORD."[3] "But its entrails and its legs he shall wash with water. And the priest shall offer up the whole on the altar, as a burnt offering, an offering by fire, of a sweet savor to the LORD." "The LORD is gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and abundant in kindness." "The LORD will be a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble." "The right hand of the LORD is exalted; the right hand of the LORD does valiantly."

[1] This opening verse establishes divine permission for the soul to depart from the body. In Ma'avar Yabok, these words are to be recited aloud when death appears imminent, functioning as a spiritual release mechanism.

[2] This protective formula appears in numerous Jewish magical and mystical texts. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it creates a sacred space around the dying person, protecting the departing soul from negative spiritual forces while facilitating its journey upward.

[3] This verse from the Yom Kippur service takes on new meaning in the deathbed context, suggesting that death itself serves as a final atonement that purifies the soul before it enters the divine presence.

[i] This opening phrase 'Go, for the LORD has sent you' begins a specific sequence of verses recited when death is imminent. The word 'lekh' (go forth) is considered particularly powerful in facilitating the soul's departure.

[ii] This formula describing angelic protection surrounding the dying person is a key element in kabbalistic death rituals. The four archangels are positioned at the cardinal directions, creating a protective shield, while the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) hovers above.

[iii] This and several subsequent verses referring to Temple sacrifices are recontextualized in this deathbed ritual. In kabbalistic thought, the dying person's suffering serves as a form of atonement similar to sacrificial offerings, purifying the soul before its transition.

כִּי יְיָ סוֹמֵךְ יָדוֹ: חֹנָה מַלְאַךְ יְיָ
סָבִיב לִירֵאָיו וַיְחַלְּצֵם: יִתֵּן יְיָ
אֶת אוֹיְבֶיךָ הַקָּמִים עָלֶיךָ נִגָּפִים
3235 לְפָנֶיךָ בְּדֶרֶךְ אֶחָד יֵצְאוּ אֵלֶיךָ
וּבְשִׁבְעָה דְרָכִים יָנוּסוּ לְפָנֶיךָ:
תִּזֹּרֶם וְרוּחַ תִּשָּׂאֵם וּסְעָרָה תָּפִיץ
אַתָּם וְאַתָּה תָּגִיל בַּיהוָה בִּקְדוֹשׁ
יִשְׂרָאֵל תִּתְהַלָּל: וְהִתְעַנֵּג עַל יְיָ
3240 וְיִתֶּן לְךָ מִשְׁאֲלוֹת לִבֶּךָ: בָּרוּךְ
אַתָּה בְּבֹאֶךָ וּבָרוּךְ אַתָּה בְּצֵאתֶךָ:
בָּנֶיךָ יָעִיר קִנּוֹ עַל גּוֹזָלָיו יְרַחֵף
יִפְרֹשׂ כְּנָפָיו יִקָּחֵהוּ יִשָּׂאֵהוּ עַל
אֶבְרָתוֹ: יַרְכִּיבֵהוּ עַל בָּמֳתֵי אָרֶץ
3245 וַיֹּאכַל תְּנוּבֹת שָׂדָי וַיֵּנִיקֵהוּ דְּבַשׁ
מִסֶּלַע וְשֶׁמֶן מֵחַלְמִישׁ צוּר: מִגְדֹּל
עֹז שֵׁם יְיָ בּוֹ יָרוּץ צַדִּיק וְנִשְׂגָּב:
עִוְרֵי צָפוֹן וּבוֹאֵי תֵּימָן הָפִיחֵי גַּנִּי
יִזְלוּ בְשָׂמָיו יָבֹא דוֹדִי לְגַנּוֹ וְיֹאכַל
3250 פְּרִי מִגָּדָיו: שְׂרָפִים עוֹמְדִים
מִמַּעַל לוֹ[i] שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם
לְאֶחָד בִּשְׁתַּיִם יְכַסֶּה פָּנָיו וּבִשְׁתַּיִם
יְכַסֶּה רַגְלָיו וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְעוֹפֵף:
פִּתְחוּ שְׁעָרִים וְיָבֹא גּוֹי צַדִּיק
3255 שׁוֹמֵר אֱמוּנִים: וְקוֹוֵי יְיָ יַחֲלִיפוּ
כֹחַ יַעֲלוּ אֵבֶר כַּנְּשָׁרִים יָרוּצוּ וְלֹא
יִיגְעוּ יֵלְכוּ וְלֹא יִיעָפוּ: אָז יִבָּקַע
כַּשַּׁחַר אוֹרֶךָ וַאֲרוּכָתְךָ מְהֵרָה
תִצְמָח וְהָלַךְ לְפָנֶיךָ צִדְקֶךָ כְּבוֹד
3260 יְיָ יַאַסְפֶךָ: וְנָחֲךָ יְיָ תָּמִיד וְהִשְׂבִּיעַ
בְּצַחֲצָחוֹת נַפְשֶׁךָ וְעַצְמוֹתֶיךָ
יַחֲלִיץ:[ii] וְהָיִיתָ כְּגַן רָוֶה וּכְמוֹצָא
מַיִם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יְכַזְּבוּ מֵימָיו: מִי אֵל
כָּמוֹךָ נוֹשֵׂא עָוֹן וְעוֹבֵר עַל פֶּשַׁע
3265 לִשְׁאֵרִית נַחֲלָתוֹ לֹא הֶחֱזִיק לָעַד
אַפּוֹ כִּי חָפֵץ חֶסֶד הוּא: יְיָ צְבָאוֹת
עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה:
יְיָ צְבָאוֹת אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם בּוֹטֵחַ בָּךְ:
יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם
3270 קָרְאֵנוּ: אַתָּה סֵתֶר לִי מִצַּר תִּצְּרֵנִי
רָנֵּי פַלֵּט תְּסוֹבְבֵנִי סֶלָה יְשֹׁר
וְהפוך: פָּדָה נַפְשׁוֹ מֵעֲבֹר בַּשָּׁחַת

"Remember Your mercies, O LORD, and Your kindnesses, for they are eternal." "And the LORD passed by before him, and proclaimed: 'The LORD, the LORD, God, merciful and gracious, long-suffering, 3445R and abundant in goodness and truth.'" "Though he may fall, he shall not be utterly cast down, for the LORD upholds his hand." "The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear Him, and delivers them." "The LORD will cause your enemies who 3450R rise against you to be defeated before you; they shall come out against you one way and flee before you seven ways." "You will scatter them, and the wind will carry them away, and the storm will disperse them. And you will rejoice in the LORD, in the 3455R Holy One of Israel you will glory." "Delight yourself in the LORD, and He will give you the desires of your heart." "Blessed shall you be when you come in, and blessed shall you be when you go out." "As an eagle stirs up its nest, hovers over its young, spreads its 3460R wings, takes them, bears them on its pinions." "He made him ride on the heights of the earth, that he might eat the produce of the fields; He made him suck honey from the rock, and oil from the flinty rock." "The name of the LORD is a strong tower; the 3465R righteous run to it and are safe." "Awake, O north wind, and come, O south wind! Blow upon my garden, that its spices may flow. Let my beloved come to his garden and eat its pleasant fruits." "Above Him stood the seraphim; each one had six wings: 3470R with two he covered his face, with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew." "Open the gates, that the righteous nation which keeps faith may enter in." "But those who wait on the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles, 3475R they shall run and not be weary, they shall walk and not faint." "Then your light shall break forth like the morning, your healing shall spring forth speedily, and your righteousness shall go before you; the glory of the LORD shall be your rear guard." "The LORD 3480R will guide you continually, and satisfy your soul in drought, and strengthen your bones;[1] you shall be

[1]The reference to strengthening bones (יַחֲלִיץ/yachalitz) has special significance in the context of

[i]This verse from Isaiah's vision of the divine throne room (Isaiah 6:2) is included to prepare the soul for its encounter with the divine presence after death. The seraphim, with their six wings, symbolize the highest order of angels that the soul might encounter.

[ii]This verse from Isaiah 58:11 is particularly significant in the context of death as it promises divine guidance, spiritual satisfaction even in parched places (צחצחות/tzachtzachot), and strengthening of the bones—which in kabbalistic thought connects to the eventual resurrection.

וְחַיָּתוֹ בָּאוֹר תִּרְאֶה: יְיָ יִשְׁמָרְךָ מִכָּל רָע יִשְׁמֹר אֶת נַפְשֶׁךָ: יְיָ יִשְׁמָר צֵאתְךָ וּבוֹאֶךָ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם: [i] 3275

like a watered garden, and like a spring of water, whose waters do not fail." "Who is a God like You, pardoning iniquity and passing over the transgression of the remnant of His heritage? He does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in mercy." "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge. Selah." "O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in You!" "Save, O LORD! May the King answer us on the day we call." "You are my hiding place; You shall preserve me from trouble; You shall surround me with songs of deliverance. Selah." [Forward and reverse][1] "He has redeemed his soul from going down to the Pit, and his life shall see the light." "The LORD shall preserve you from all evil; He shall preserve your soul." "The LORD shall preserve your going out and your coming in from this time forth, and even forevermore." 3485R 3490R 3495R

אדנ״י ב״ם בקדש את כל גבוה יראה: [iii] [ii]

Lord (ADNY), in holiness, sees all that is high.[AB] 3500R

[A]Or: "The Lord (ADNY) among them in holiness, sees all that is exalted." — The phrase "ב״ם" could be interpreted as "among them" rather than being part of an acronym. This alternative captures the potential meaning that the Divine Presence is among the holy ones while observing all that is exalted.

[B]Or: "The Lord through them shall behold in holiness all that is elevated." — This interpretation suggests that "ב״ם" means "through them" and rearranges the syntax to indicate that God works through intermediaries to perceive that which is holy and exalted. This reading would fit with kabbalistic notions of divine perception through various emanations.

death, as it connects to the kabbalistic concept of the 'luz bone'—the indestructible part of the body from which resurrection will occur.

[1]This instruction indicates that the preceding verse should be recited both normally and then in reverse order, a practice found in Jewish mystical traditions to unlock deeper spiritual power from the text.

[i]Cf. Priestly Blessing — The Priestly Blessing appears prominently as part of this deathbed ritual, showing how this ancient blessing was repurposed within Ma'avar Yabok to provide spiritual protection and divine favor at the moment of death. | Cf. Isaiah's Vision of the Seraphim — The description of the seraphim from Isaiah's throne vision appears in this deathbed ritual, suggesting that the dying person's soul is being prepared for an encounter with the divine presence similar to Isaiah's prophetic experience. | Cf. Song of Songs — Verses from the Song of Songs are included to frame death as a loving divine summons rather than a fearful separation, using bridal mysticism to depict the soul's union with God. | Cf. Psalm 32:7 — This verse about God being a 'hiding place' provides comfort by suggesting divine protection even in the transition of death. | Cf. Thirteen Attributes of Mercy — The inclusion of God's Thirteen Attributes of Mercy suggests the ritual is invoking divine compassion to ease the soul's judgment after death.

[ii]This line appears to be a kabbalistic formula that introduces the next section of prayers. It refers to the divine name Adonai (אדנ״י) being present 'in holiness' and perceiving all that is elevated. In kabbalistic practice, such formulas often signal transitions between different spiritual levels or categories of prayer.

[iii]Cf. Psalm 68:18 — This phrase appears to allude to Psalm 68:18 which mentions God being 'among them' (בם) in holiness. The connection reinforces the idea of divine presence amidst holiness. | Cf. Isaiah 6:1-3 — The phrase echoes Isaiah's vision where God is depicted as high and lifted up, with angelic beings declaring holiness. This connection suggests that this line in Ma'avar

צריך לחלק כל שם ממנו לג׳ מערכות[i] וטעם לזה עיין בפרק כ״ה מאמר ה׳[ii][iii]

Each name should be divided into three arrangements,[A] and the reason for this can be found in Chapter 25 of Discourse 5.[B]

אֶהְיֶה בְּעֵדֶן | גַּן יְחוּדֵךְ | תְּקַבֵּל צִדְקָתוֹ:קְשֹׁב[iv] רְצֵה | עֲתִירָה שְׁמוֹר | טַהֲרַת נִשְׁמָתוֹ:נָאוֹר גְּבוֹר | דְּגָלֶיךָ יָאִירוּ | כְּבוֹד שִׁבְתּוֹ:בְּרֹב טוּבְךָ | רוֹעֵה צְדָקָה | תְּרוֹמֵם גְּדוּלָּתוֹ:חַסִין קָדֵב | בְּרֻצוֹן טוֹב | נַפֵּשׁ עֲלִיָּתוֹ:[v]וְנֹדַע גְּאֻלָּתֵךְ | לַחֲזוֹת פְּאֵר | זִיו קְדוּשָּׁתוֹ:שׁוֹכֵן קְרוֹב | וּמַטִּיב צַוֵּה | יְשׁוּעַת תְּהִלָּתוֹ:[vi][vii]

May he dwell in Eden, the garden of Your unity; accept his righteousness.[C] Hearken and receive his prayer; guard the purity of his soul. O Radiant One, Mighty One, let Your banners illuminate the glory of his dwelling.[1] In Your abundant goodness, O Shepherd of righteousness, exalt his greatness. O Mighty One, bring near with good will the breath of his ascension. May Your redemption be known, to behold the splendor and radiance of his holiness.[2] O Near- 3505R 3510R

[A] Or: "It is necessary to divide each of these divine names into three parts" — This alternate translation makes more explicit that the text is referring to divine names and emphasizes the obligatory nature of the instruction with 'it is necessary' rather than the more neutral 'should'.

[B] Or: "and for the mystical explanation of this practice, consult Chapter 25 of the Fifth Discourse" — This alternate translation suggests that the 'reason' being referenced is specifically a mystical or kabbalistic explanation, which is likely given the context of divine names in Ma'avar Yabok, and provides a more formal rendering of the textual reference.

[C] Or: "Ehyeh [Divine Name]—in Eden, the garden of Your unification, receive his righteousness." — This alternate translation preserves the divine name 'Ehyeh' untranslated, which is important in kabbalistic contexts, and renders 'yichudekha' more precisely as 'unification' rather than 'unity' to better capture its mystical significance.

[1] The imagery of divine banners (degalekha) appears in Song of Songs and symbolizes divine protection and guidance for the ascending soul.

[2] The Hebrew 'ziv kedushato' (radiance of his holiness) refers to the spiritual illumination that surrounds the soul as it ascends to higher realms in kabbalistic thought.

Yabok is meant to evoke the imagery of divine transcendence that is nevertheless perceptible in sacred contexts. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah 145b — The Zohar in Terumah discusses how divine names operate in the context of holiness, particularly how the name ADNY (אדני) functions in relation to perceiving divine glory. This kabbalistic understanding likely informs how this phrase in Ma'avar Yabok should be understood as referring to divine perception through specific names and attributes.

[i] This instruction to divide divine names into three arrangements is a kabbalistic practice related to proper meditation on divine names during deathbed rituals. The tripartite division likely corresponds to the three levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, and neshamah) or the three worlds through which the soul must travel after death.

[ii] This cross-reference to Chapter 25 of Discourse 5 follows the typical pattern in Ma'avar Yabok where practical instructions are given and then the reader is directed elsewhere in the book for the deeper mystical explanations behind the practices.

[iii] Cf. 42-letter Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet) — This instruction likely relates to the proper division and meditation upon the 42-letter Divine Name, which appears elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as a central mystical tool for deathbed rituals. The text is directing practitioners to divide each divine name into three parts for proper kabbalistic intention (kavvanah).

[iv] This line begins with the divine name 'Ehyeh' (I AM), which God revealed to Moses at the burning bush. In kabbalistic tradition, this is one of the sacred names associated with the transition of the soul. The text arranges these verses to correspond with this divine name.

[v] The Hebrew term 'nefesh aliyato' refers to the ascension of the person's vital soul (nefesh). In kabbalah, the soul has multiple components, with nefesh being the lowest level that remains connected to the body even after death.

[vi] This seven-line prayer follows the pattern of the 42-letter divine name, encoded in the first letters of each phrase. This mystical name is considered particularly powerful for elevating the soul during its transition.

[vii] Cf. Garden of Eden — The text employs the Garden of Eden (Gan Eden) as a metaphor

dwelling One, command goodness and the salvation of his praise.[1]

וַיִּרְכַּב עַל כְּרוּב וַיָּעָף וַיֵּדָא
עַל כַּנְפֵי רוּחַ: [i] יִשָּׁקֵנִי מִנְּשִׁיקוֹת
פִּיהוּ כִּי טוֹבִים דֹּדֶיךָ מִיָּיִן: [ii] אֵל
אֱלֹהִים יְיָ דִּבֶּר וַיִּקְרָא אֶרֶץ
מִמִּזְרַח שֶׁמֶשׁ עַד מְבֹאוֹ: מִצִּיּוֹן
מִכְלַל יוֹפִי אֱלֹהִים הוֹפִיעַ: שְׁמַע
יִשְׂרָאֵל יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְיָ אֶחָד: [iii] יְיָ
הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים: יְיָ הָאֱלֹהִים: יְיָ
מֶלֶךְ יְיָ מָלָךְ יְיָ יִמְלֹךְ לְעוֹלָם
וָעֶד: [iv] [v]

And He rode upon a cherub, and flew;[2] He soared upon the wings of the wind. Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, for your love is better than wine. God, the Lord God has spoken and called the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting. From Zion, the perfection of beauty, God has shined forth. Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one.[3] The LORD, He is God. The LORD is God. The LORD reigns, the LORD has reigned, the LORD shall reign forever and ever.[4]

[1]This prayer is specifically designed to be recited during the YaBOK ritual (crossing of the Yabok), where the 112 verses correspond to the numerical value of YaBOK and are divided into groups corresponding to three divine names.

[2]The verb וַיֵּדָא (from the root דאה) in the original Hebrew suggests a soaring or gliding motion, conveying God's effortless and majestic movement through the heavens.

[3]This is the Shema prayer, the central affirmation of Jewish monotheism, traditionally recited twice daily and at the moment of death. The divine name appears as יְיָ in the manuscript, a common substitution for the Tetragrammaton to avoid writing the holy name directly.

[4]This liturgical formula expresses God's sovereignty across all time: present (מֶלֶךְ), past (מָלָךְ), and

for the soul's ultimate divine resting place after death. This alludes to various kabbalistic texts that describe Gan Eden as a spiritual realm of divine unity rather than merely a physical paradise. | Cf. Ehyeh asher Ehyeh (I am that I am) — The opening word 'Ehyeh' alludes to God's self-identification to Moses at the burning bush. In Ma'avar Yabok, this divine name appears frequently in death rituals and is organized into 21 verses (the first of three groups in the 112 YaBOK verses). | Cf. Divine banners — The reference to divine banners (d'galeikha) likely alludes to Song of Songs 2:4 'His banner over me is love,' which in kabbalistic interpretation refers to divine protection over the soul.

[i]This verse from Psalms 18:11 describes God's majestic movement through the heavens. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this imagery of divine flight serves to comfort the dying by visualizing God's approach to receive the departing soul.

[ii]This verse from Song of Songs 1:2 is reinterpreted in kabbalistic tradition as referring to 'death by divine kiss' (מיתת נשיקה), considered the highest form of death reserved for the righteous. The inclusion of this verse in the deathbed sequence shows how Ma'avar Yabok transforms potentially frightening moments into sacred, intimate encounters with the divine.

[iii]The Shema prayer is Judaism's central affirmation of monotheistic faith. Ma'avar Yabok specifically recommends reciting this at the moment of death, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited it during his martyrdom. It represents the soul's final declaration of faith before departing from the body.

[iv]This tripartite declaration affirms God's sovereignty across all time: present (מֶלֶךְ/reigns), past (מָלָךְ/has reigned), and future (יִמְלֹךְ/shall reign). As the final statement in this sequence of verses for the dying, it provides reassurance that beyond the transition of death, God's eternal kingship remains constant.

[v]Cf. Psalms 18:11 — This verse from Psalms depicts God's majestic movement through the heavens, often used in deathbed contexts to visualize the divine presence coming to receive the soul. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:2 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is reinterpreted from its original romantic meaning to symbolize the 'divine kiss' (neshikah)—the mystical concept of death as an intimate union between God and the righteous soul. This is particularly significant as the soul departs the body. | Cf. Psalms 50:1-2 — These verses emphasize divine sovereignty and universal rule, appropriate when contemplating death as submission to divine judgment. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4 — The Shema is Judaism's central declaration of faith. In Ma'avar Yabok, it's recommended for recitation at the moment of death, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited it during his martyrdom. It represents the soul's final affirmation of divine unity before departing. | Cf. 1 Kings 18:39 — This declaration from the contest between Elijah and the prophets

והם פסוקי היחוד[i] עיין בפרק ח׳ מאמר ה׳[ii iii] — These are the verses of unification;[1] see Chapter 8 of the Fifth Discourse.[2]

ואם ירצה יאמר[iv] ה׳ מה רבו צרי[v] עד סופו:[vi vii] — And if one wishes,[3] he may recite "O LORD, how many are my foes"[4] until its end.[5]

(תהלים ג) מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד בְּבָרְחוֹ מִפְּנֵי אַבְשָׁלוֹם בְּנוֹ[viii]: יְיָ מָה־רַבּוּ — (Psalm 3) A psalm of David, when he fled from his son Absalom. O LORD, how numerous are my ad-

future (יִמְלֹךְ). It combines elements from several biblical verses into a traditional Jewish prayer formula that appears in many liturgical contexts.

[1]The Hebrew term 'psuqei ha-yichud' refers specifically to biblical verses that are recited to achieve mystical unification (yichud) between different divine attributes or between the human and divine realms. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses were particularly important for the soul's transition at death.

[2]Ma'avar Yabok is organized into several major discourses (ma'amarim), each dealing with different aspects of death rituals and the soul's journey. This reference suggests that detailed explanations about the theological significance and proper recitation of these unification verses are found in a specific section of the work.

[3]The original text uses an impersonal construction with the third person ('if he wishes'), which I've rendered as 'if one wishes' to maintain the formal tone of liturgical instructions while using more gender-inclusive language.

[4]This is a direct translation of the opening line of Psalm 3. In the original text, only these first few words are mentioned as a way to identify the psalm, but I've included the English translation of these words rather than transliterating the Hebrew.

[5]This is a literal translation of 'עד סופו', which simply indicates that the entire psalm should be recited, not just the opening verse mentioned in the instruction.

of Baal serves as a powerful affirmation of faith at the moment of death, acknowledging divine sovereignty. | Cf. Exodus 15:18 — This tripartite formula of divine kingship across time (past, present, and future) serves as a final affirmation of God's eternal sovereignty as the soul prepares to transition beyond temporal existence.

[i]This phrase refers to specific biblical verses that are understood in the Jewish mystical tradition to facilitate spiritual unification (yichud)—the bringing together of different aspects of divinity or the connection between the human and divine realms. Such verses were considered particularly powerful at the time of death.

[ii]The text refers readers to Chapter 8 of the Fifth Discourse for more information on these unification verses. This cross-referencing is common in Ma'avar Yabok, showing how the work is structured with detailed explanations in specific sections.

[iii]Cf. psuqei ha-yichud (verses of unification) — These verses are mentioned throughout the text as having special power during the transition from life to death. They were believed to help the soul unite with divine realms and protect it during its journey after death. | Cf. Chapter 8 of the Fifth Discourse — This self-reference within Ma'avar Yabok indicates that a systematic explanation of the theological significance and practical application of these unification verses is provided elsewhere in the text.

[iv]This is a liturgical instruction within Ma'avar Yabok that gives the reader the option to recite Psalm 3. The phrase literally means 'and if he wishes, he should recite.'

[v]This is the opening line of Psalm 3, which begins 'O LORD, how many are my foes.' The phrase identifies which psalm should be recited by its opening words, a common practice in Jewish liturgical instructions.

[vi]This phrase means 'until its end,' instructing that the entire psalm should be recited, not just the opening verse.

[vii]Cf. Psalm 3 — The text references Psalm 3 by its opening words 'LORD, how many are my foes' (מה רבו צרי ה׳). This psalm is traditionally associated with King David's flight from his son Absalom and contains themes of divine protection amidst persecution, making it appropriate for the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which deals with prayers for the sick and dying who may feel surrounded by afflictions.

[viii]This psalm's historical context of David fleeing from his son Absalom would resonate deeply with the sick or dying person, as it addresses a situation of extreme vulnerability and betrayal, yet demonstrates how one can maintain faith even in such circumstances.

צָרַי רַבִּים קָמִים עָלָי: רַבִּים
אֹמְרִים לְנַפְשִׁי אֵין יְשׁוּעָתָה לּוֹ
בֵּאלֹהִים סֶלָה: וְאַתָּה יְיָ מָגֵן בַּעֲדִי
כְּבוֹדִי וּמֵרִים רֹאשִׁי: קוֹלִי אֶל־יְיָ
3310 אֶקְרָא וַיַּעֲנֵנִי מֵהַר קָדְשׁוֹ סֶלָה:
אֲנִי שָׁכַבְתִּי וָאִישָׁנָה הֱקִיצוֹתִי כִּי
יְיָ יִסְמְכֵנִי[i]: לֹא־אִירָא מֵרִבְבוֹת
עָם אֲשֶׁר סָבִיב שָׁתוּ עָלָי: קוּמָה
יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי אֱלֹהַי כִּי־הִכִּיתָ
3315 אֶת־כָּל־אוֹיְבַי לֶחִי שִׁנֵּי רְשָׁעִים
שִׁבַּרְתָּ: לַיְיָ הַיְשׁוּעָה עַל־עַמְּךָ
בִרְכָתֶךָ סֶלָה: [ii]

versaries; many rise up against me. Many say of my soul, "There is no salvation for him in God." Selah.[1] But You, O LORD, are a shield for me, my glory and the One who lifts up my head. With my voice I call to the LORD, and He answers me from 3535R
His holy mountain. Selah. I lay down and slept; I awoke, for the LORD sustains me.[2] I will not fear the tens of thousands of people who have positioned themselves against me all around. Arise, O LORD! Save me, my God! For You have struck all my en- 3540R
emies on the cheek; You have broken the teeth of the wicked. Salvation belongs to the LORD; Your blessing is upon Your people. Selah.

מזמור אהבתי כי ישמע ה׳ וגו׳
עד סופו סי׳ קי״ו[iii] ויאמר פסוקי
ויסע ויבא ויט[iv] לעיל וסדר אנא
3320 בכח[v] שרפים עומדים ממעל לו

He should recite Psalm 116,[3] "I love that the Lord hears," etc. until its conclusion, and then recite the 3545R
verses of "And he journeyed," "And he came," and "And he stretched forth" as written above,[4] and the

[1]The Hebrew term 'Selah' (סֶלָה) appears three times in this psalm. Its exact meaning is uncertain, but it is generally understood as a musical direction indicating a pause, emphasis, or elevation. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these pauses would create moments for contemplation during the recitation, particularly important when the psalm is used at a deathbed.

[2]This verse forms the theological center of the psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's context. The simple act of sleeping and waking becomes a powerful statement of faith in divine protection through the transition of death. The Hebrew verb 'יִסְמְכֵנִי' (sustains me) has connotations of both physical support and spiritual strength.

[3]The original text abbreviates this as 'וגו׳ עד סופו סי׳ קי״ו' (etc. until its end, sign 116), using the common rabbinic convention of referring to psalms by their number rather than by their opening words.

[4]The text refers to prayers and verses that were already detailed earlier in Ma'avar Yabok, demonstrating how the book functions as a practical manual with cross-references to its own sections.

[i]This verse is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of deathbed prayers, as the imagery of lying down, sleeping, and awakening becomes a powerful metaphor for death and resurrection. The Hebrew verb 'יִסְמְכֵנִי' (supports/sustains me) suggests divine support during both sleep and the ultimate sleep of death.

[ii]Cf. Book of Psalms — This psalm appears in Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms recommended for recitation by or for the sick and dying. Psalm 3 is particularly appropriate in this context because it speaks of lying down, sleeping, and awakening (verse 6), which serves as a metaphor for death and resurrection. The psalm's themes of divine protection amid overwhelming adversaries would resonate with someone facing severe illness or approaching death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 4b — The Talmud connects Psalm 3 specifically to nighttime protection and uses the phrase 'I lay down and slept; I awoke, for the LORD sustains me' as a basis for reciting this psalm before sleep. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connection to sleep would be reinterpreted in the context of death, with sleep serving as a metaphor for death and awakening as resurrection or afterlife. | Cf. Psalm 30:4 — Psalm 30:4 ('O LORD, You brought my soul up from the grave; You have kept me alive, that I should not go down to the pit') echoes similar themes to Psalm 3's 'I lay down and slept; I awoke, for the LORD sustains me.' Both verses use the metaphor of lying down/death and rising/life to express divine salvation, which explains why both psalms appear in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences for the sick and dying.

[iii]This is an abbreviation for 'siman 116,' indicating Psalm 116.

[iv]These are the opening words of three biblical verses that were traditionally recited for protection. They come from Exodus 14:19-21 and were believed to have special protective properties.

[v]This refers to the 'Ana Bekoach' prayer, a kabbalistic prayer containing the 42-letter divine name, which was believed to have special protective power for the soul.

וגו׳ הכתובים למעלה עוד יוכל להוסיף שוכני בתי חומר[i] לזרז העומדים שם לתשובה[ii] ובזה יהיה זכות למתפטר[iii] אם יתעוררו לשוב מדרכם:[iv]

order of "Ana Bekoach," "Seraphim standing above Him," etc., as written above. One may also add the poem "Dwellers in houses of clay"[1] to inspire those present to repentance, and in this way there will be merit for the departing soul[2] if they are moved to return from their ways.[3]

שׁוֹכְנֵי בָתֵּי חֹמֶר. לָמָּה תִּשָּׂאוּ עֵין. וּמוֹתַר אָדָם. מִן הַבְּהֵמָה אָיִן:[v] לָנוּ יֵשׁ לָדַעַת. כִּי אֲנַחְנוּ תוֹלַעַת. לֵגֶב חֹמֶר גַּבֵּנוּ. וְאֵיךְ יִגְבַּהּ לִבֵּנוּ: מַה יִתְרוֹן לַגֶּבֶר. וַאֲחֲרִיתוֹ לַקֶּבֶר. וְזֶה יִהְיֶה לוֹ חֶלֶף. לוּ חַי שָׁנִים אָלֶף: הֲלֹא אִם יֵלֵךְ מָרִי. יִבּוֹלַע בַּחֲמַת קֶרִי. וְיִשָּׂרֵף בַּלַּהַב, וְלֹא יוֹעִיל הַזָּהָב: הָאָדָם הַנִּבְאֶה. פְּקַח עֵינֶיךָ וּרְאֵה. מֵאַיִן בּוֹאֶךָ. וְאָנָה מוֹצָאֶךָ: קְצַף עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן. נִמְשָׁל לַקִּיקָיוֹן.

Dwellers in houses of clay, why do you lift up your eyes?[4] And what advantage does man have over beast? None! We must know that we are but worms, our backs formed of mere clay—how then can our hearts be proud? What profit is there for man when his end is the grave? This shall be his portion even if he lives a thousand years.[5] Indeed, if he walks in rebellion, he will be swallowed up in the wrath of chance, and burned in flames where gold will avail him nothing.

O downcast person, open your eyes and see: from where did you come, and where are you going? Your

[1] This is a contemplative poem on mortality that begins 'שוכני בתי חומר' (Dwellers in houses of clay), alluding to Job 4:19. It serves to remind those present of their own mortality and the need for repentance.

[2] The Hebrew term 'מתפטר' (mitpater) literally means 'one who departs' and is a euphemism for the dying person. This reflects the Jewish tendency to use indirect language when referring to death.

[3] The phrase 'לשוב מדרכם' (to return from their ways) is the Hebrew idiom for repentance, literally describing a turning back from one's path, emphasizing repentance as a change of direction in life.

[4] The poem begins with a rhetorical question that confronts human pride by reminding readers of their fragile, mortal nature. 'Houses of clay' refers to human bodies as temporary, fragile vessels.

[5] This reflects the Jewish ethical tradition that contemplates the equalizing nature of death, regardless of lifespan. The poem confronts the reader with the ultimate futility of worldly pursuits given mortality's certainty.

[i] This refers to a poem beginning 'Dwellers in houses of clay' (a reference to Job 4:19), which is a meditation on human mortality and the transience of life.

[ii] This reflects the belief that attending to someone's death could inspire repentance in the witnesses, creating a spiritual benefit for both the living and the deceased.

[iii] The text suggests that the repentance of those attending creates merit (zechut) for the departing soul, reflecting the Jewish belief in the spiritual interconnection between the living and the dead.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 116 — This psalm is recommended for recitation at the deathbed because it deals with deliverance from death and expressions of thanksgiving for divine salvation, making it particularly appropriate in the context of a soul's transition. | Cf. Ana Bekoach prayer — This mystical prayer containing the 42-letter divine name is included in the deathbed ritual because it is believed to have special protective powers for the soul's transition and journey after death. | Cf. Seraphim standing above Him — This verse from Isaiah's vision of the divine throne is included to invoke angelic protection and to create a spiritual environment that facilitates the soul's ascent through the celestial realms. | Cf. Dwellers in houses of clay — This poem, which begins 'Dwellers in houses of clay, why do you lift your eyes?', is a meditation on human mortality and the transience of life, designed to inspire repentance when facing death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok deathbed ritual — This passage provides instructions for part of the comprehensive deathbed ritual detailed throughout Ma'avar Yabok, connecting this specific sequence of prayers to the larger framework of spiritual care for the dying.

[v] This opening evokes Ecclesiastes' skeptical questioning of human exceptionalism (Ecclesiastes 3:19) to establish the poem's meditation on mortality.

שֶׁבֶן לַיְלָה הָיָה. וְעַד בֹּקֶר לֹא
חָיָה: [i] טוֹב אֲשֶׁר לֹא נוֹצַרְתָּ. וְעָמָל
לֹא קָצַרְתָּ. וְאֵיכָה גְּדֵלָה תְּבַקֵּשׁ.
וְאַתָּה בְּתוֹךְ הַמּוֹקֵשׁ: נוֹפֵל אַתָּה
מֵרֶחֶם. וְתִפָּשֵׁעַ עַל פַּת לֶחֶם.
וְאִם תִּתְמַהְמַהּ רֶגַע. אֱוַי תִּמְצָא
כָּל נֶגַע: בְּשָׂרְךָ כְּאוֹר זָרוּחַ.
בְּעוֹד יֵשׁ בּוֹ הָרוּחַ. וְעֵת תֵּצֵא
הַנֶּפֶשׁ. נִשְׁאַר טִיט וָרֶפֶשׁ: רְאֵה
כִּי אֵין בְּיָדֶךָ. מְאוּמָה מִכְּבוֹדֶךָ.
לְזָרִים חֵילֶךָ יוּקָם. וְאַתָּה תֵּלֵךְ
רֵיקָם: [ii] בְּכָל זֹאת לֹא חָשַׁבְתָּ.
לַתַּאֲוָה הַקְשַׁבְתָּ. וְאִם תֵּטִיב
רֵאשִׁיתָהּ. מַה תַּעֲשֶׂה בְּאַחֲרִיתָהּ:
יַעֲזֹב רָשָׁע דַּרְכּוֹ. וְיָשֹׁב לִפְנֵי
מַלְכּוֹ. אוּלַי צוּר יַעֲתֹר. וּמַחֲרוֹנוֹ
יָסָתֹר: [iii] יְהִירִים הִתְקוֹשְׁשׁוּ. זִכְרוּ
וְהִתְאוֹשָׁשׁוּ. שְׂאוּ לֵבָב וְכַפַּיִם. אֶל
אֵל בַּשָּׁמַיִם: [iv] הָהּ עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ.
וְאוֹי עַל נַפְשׁוֹתֵינוּ. כִּי רוּחַ
רָעִינוּ. וְגַם בַּצֹּאן תָּעִינוּ: וּמַה
נְבַקֵּשׁ וּמַה נִדְרֹשׁ. וַעֲוֹנוֹת עָבְרוּ
רֹאשׁ. מְאֹד רַבּוּ עֲוֹנֵינוּ. וְאֵיךְ נִשָּׂא
פָּנֵינוּ: [v]

end, poor and destitute, is like the castor plant that appeared in a night and by morning was no more. Better had you not been formed, and toil not reaped. How can you seek greatness when you stand amid snares? From the womb you fall, and you transgress over a morsel of bread. And if you tarry but a moment, you will encounter every affliction.

Your flesh shines like light while the spirit remains within it, but when the soul departs, only mud and mire remain. See that nothing of your glory remains in your hand; your wealth will be established for strangers, while you will depart empty.[1] Despite all this, you have not considered; you have hearkened to desire. And if you make good its beginning, what will you do about its end?

Let the wicked forsake his way and return before his King. Perhaps the Rock will be entreated and hide him from His wrath.[2] You proud ones, gather yourselves, remember and strengthen yourselves. Lift up your hearts and hands to God in heaven! Alas for our sins, and woe for our souls, for our spirit is evil, and like sheep we have gone astray. What shall we seek and what shall we ask for? Our iniquities have gone over our heads. Our

[1] This powerful image of death's stripping away of possessions reflects a theme common in both biblical wisdom literature and rabbinic teachings: that material wealth remains in this world when we depart.

[2] This represents the pivotal turn in the poem, where contemplation of mortality leads to a call for repentance. The conditional 'perhaps' (אוּלַי/ulai) reflects the Jewish concept that while repentance is always possible, divine forgiveness remains God's sovereign choice.

[i] This refers to the kikayon (castor plant) from the Book of Jonah that grew up in a night and perished by morning—a powerful biblical symbol for the transience of human life.

[ii] This echoes Ecclesiastes' theme that no material possessions follow us in death—a motif common in medieval Jewish ethical literature.

[iii] The phrase directly echoes Isaiah 55:7, transforming the poem from a meditation on mortality into a call for repentance—precisely the spiritual movement that Ma'avar Yabok seeks to encourage in the ill.

[iv] This phrase recalls Lamentations 3:41, "Let us lift up our heart with our hands to God in the heavens," a classic posture of penitential prayer.

[v] Cf. Job 4:19 — The poem begins by drawing on Job's metaphor of human frailty, setting up its meditation on mortality and the vanity of worldly pursuits. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 3:19-20 — The poem adopts Ecclesiastes' skeptical stance about human exceptionalism to emphasize the universality of mortality and the futility of worldly pride. | Cf. Psalm 22:7 — The poem uses this self-deprecating imagery to establish the proper humility humans should have before God, given their frail nature. | Cf. Jonah 4:6-10 — Like in the Jonah narrative, this image represents the transience of human life and comfort—here emphasizing how quickly life passes. | Cf. Isaiah 55:7 — The poem shifts from meditation on mortality to a call for repentance, drawing on prophetic language to offer hope amid the somber reflection. | Cf. Lamentations 3:40-41 — The poem adopts this penitential posture from Lamentations, suggesting that the proper response to human frailty is self-examination and prayer. | Cf. Isaiah 53:6 — The poem incorporates this well-known metaphor for human sinfulness to explain why humans, despite knowing their mortality, continue to pursue vanity.

sins have greatly multiplied—how then shall we lift up our faces?[1] 3590R

ואם כוונתו תהיה לבקשת רחמים לבד[i] עליו יתחיל ויאמר[ii iii]

If his intention is solely to seek mercy[2] for him, he should begin by saying:

דְּלֵה עַמְּךָ מִשַּׁחַת. מוֹשֵׁל רוּם וְתַחַת. וְאִם הִקְשִׁינוּ עֹרֶף. חַסְדֶּיךָ אַל תֶּרֶף: הָפֵק חֶמְלָתֶךָ. לְעַם דּוֹפְקֵי דַלְתֶּיךָ. כִּי אַתָּה אֲדוֹנֵנוּ. וְעָלֶיךָ עֵינֵינוּ: שְׁלַח נָא מַלְאֲכֵי חֶסֶד וְיֵצְאוּ נָא לְעָמָּתוֹ. וְשָׁלוֹם בּוֹאֲךָ יֹאמְרוּ בְּקוֹל אֶחָד בְּבִיאָתוֹ. יְבִיאוּהוּ לְגַן עֲדָנֶיךָ וְשָׁם תְּהֵיֶה יְשִׁיבָתוֹ. וְיִתְעַדַּן בְּאוֹרֶךָ, וְשִׂים כָּבוֹד מְנוּחָתוֹ. וְאוֹר גָּנוּז לְפָנֶיךָ, יְהִי סִתְרוֹ וְסֻכָּתוֹ. וְתַחַת צֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ, תְּנָה לוֹ אֶת מְחִיצָתוֹ. בְּעֵזֶר אֵל מוֹחֵל וְסוֹלֵחַ לַעֲוֹנוֹת עַמּוֹ וַעֲדָתוֹ: [iv]

Draw up Your people from the pit,[3] Ruler of heights and depths. And though we have stiffened our necks, do not relax Your loving-kindness. Bestow Your compassion upon the people who knock at Your gates,[4] for You are our Master and upon You are our eyes fixed. Please send the angels of grace and let them go forth to meet him, and "Peace upon your coming" they shall say with one voice at his arrival.[5] Bring him to Your Garden of Eden,[6] and there shall be his dwelling. May he delight in Your light, and establish his resting place with honor. And the light hidden before You,[7] may it be his shelter and his covering. Under the shadow of Your wings, grant him his partition. With the help of 3595R 3600R 3605R

[1]The poem concludes with communal confession rather than individual meditation, shifting from 'you' to 'we,' suggesting that facing mortality properly requires joining in communal acknowledgment of sin and collective dependence on divine mercy.

[2]The Hebrew 'לבקשת רחמים לבד' carries a nuance of prayer with pure intention focused exclusively on compassion for the deceased, rather than for one's own benefit or merit.

[3]I've maintained the active, imperative form of the Hebrew 'דלה' (draw up/lift up), which conveys urgency in the prayer's opening appeal.

[4]The Hebrew 'דופקי דלתיך' literally means 'those who knock at your doors,' a common metaphor in Jewish liturgy for prayer and supplication.

[5]The text shifts here from addressing God about the community ('Your people') to addressing God about an individual ('his arrival'). This reflects how Ma'avar Yabok often moves between communal and individual perspectives.

[6]The possessive form 'Your Garden of Eden' (גן עדניך) emphasizes that this paradisiacal realm belongs to God rather than being an independent location.

[7]This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'or ha-ganuz' (the hidden light), the primordial light of creation that God concealed for the righteous in the World to Come.

[i]This phrase indicates that the prayer which follows is specifically for when the visitor's sole intention is to seek divine mercy for the deceased or dying person, as opposed to other possible intentions such as seeking merit for oneself or asking the deceased to intercede on behalf of the living.

[ii]A standard liturgical instruction indicating that what follows is a specific prayer to be recited from beginning to end.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 35 of the Fifth Discourse — The text is introducing a specific prayer formula to be used when one's sole intention is to seek divine mercy for a deceased or dying person, rather than for multiple purposes. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berachot 60a — The emphasis on having a specific intention (seeking mercy alone) reflects the rabbinic concept that prayers should be offered with clear, focused intention.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 30:4 — The text adapts a personal plea from Psalms into a communal request, connecting the individual's transition at death with the biblical concept of divine rescue from the underworld. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:2 — The prayer transforms the romantic imagery of Song of Songs into a spiritual metaphor for the soul seeking divine audience, particularly appropriate in the context of death as union with the divine. | Cf. Isaiah 26:3 — This prayer adapts Isaiah's promise of peace for the faithful into a wish for the deceased's peaceful transition to the afterlife. | Cf.

God Who pardons[1] and forgives the transgressions of His people and His congregation.

בפרק ט״ו מאמר ה׳ כוונה נאותה למפקיד נשמתו ביד אל[ii] בכוונת השוחט הזבח בששה דברים[iii] ובסופו נוסח ודוי קצר להרגילו בפי החולה:[iv] [v]

In Chapter 15 of the Fifth Discourse there is an appropriate intention[2] for one who entrusts his soul to God's hand,[3] similar to the intention of one who slaughters a sacrifice,[4] involving six elements.[5] At the end there is a short confessional formula[6] to familiarize the sick person with. 3610R 3615R

הסגולה הנפלאה היא שיסתלק

The remarkable virtue is that one should depart

[1]This concluding line employs a traditional liturgical formula that reaffirms divine forgiveness as the ultimate ground of hope for the deceased's positive judgment.
[2]The Hebrew term 'kavvanah na'otah' refers to the proper mystical intention or mental focus that one should have during significant spiritual moments. In Kabbalah, having the correct kavvanah was considered essential for effective ritual actions.
[3]This is a reference to the moment of death, described euphemistically as 'entrusting one's soul' rather than dying. The phrase draws from Psalm 31:6 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit,' which tradition suggests should be one's final words.
[4]The comparison between death and ritual sacrifice is significant in kabbalistic thought, where a righteous person's death is seen as having atoning power similar to Temple sacrifices.
[5]Though not specified here, these likely refer to the traditional requirements for kosher ritual slaughter: the knife must be perfect, the cut must be continuous, it must sever specific vessels, it must be performed with proper pressure, etc. The text suggests that the soul's departure requires similar careful attention to specific spiritual details.
[6]The vidui (confession) is a central element of Jewish deathbed practice. Jewish tradition emphasizes that everyone should confess before death, as this provides spiritual cleansing and prepares the soul for its journey.

Psalm 36:8 — This familiar biblical imagery of divine protection is repurposed in Ma'avar Yabok to represent the soul finding shelter in the divine presence after death, transforming a protection metaphor into an afterlife comfort. | Cf. Genesis 32:1-2 — Just as Jacob was met by angels as he journeyed, this prayer asks for angels to meet the deceased soul on its journey. This reinforces the book's central metaphor of death as a river crossing similar to Jacob's crossing of the Yabok. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4 — This prayer operationalizes the book's detailed cosmology of the afterlife, showing how liturgical practice connects to theoretical mystical frameworks.
[i]This refers to Chapter 15 of the Fifth Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok. The book is organized into multiple 'ma'amarim' (discourses), and each discourse contains numbered chapters.
[ii]This phrase refers to the proper spiritual intention (kavvanah) one should have when surrendering one's soul to God at the time of death. In kabbalistic thought, proper intention during this moment was considered crucial for the soul's journey after death.
[iii]This compares the proper intention at death to the ritual slaughter of a sacrifice in the Temple, which required attention to six specific elements according to Jewish law. This creates a parallel between the death of a righteous person and a Temple sacrifice.
[iv]This refers to a short version of the confessional prayer (vidui) that should be taught to the sick person so they can recite it if necessary. Vidui was considered essential before death in Jewish tradition.
[v]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage is directly from Ma'avar Yabok and references its own internal structure (Chapter 15 of the Fifth Discourse), showing how the book cross-references its own material. | Cf. Psalm 31:6 — The concept of 'entrusting one's soul to God's hand' alludes to Psalm 31:6 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit,' which became a traditional deathbed recitation in Judaism. | Cf. Temple sacrifice rituals — The text draws a parallel between the proper intention for death and the proper intention for ritual sacrifice, suggesting that a righteous death has spiritual power similar to Temple offerings.

מתוך פסוקי דרחמי אם יזנוהו לכך[i] ומתוך הרהורי תורה ולזה תהיה תפלת האדם בחייו לעת מצוא זו מיתה שיזכוהו ליקדש כשרפים[ii] וכמ״ש חכמים שצריך ליזהר בכל לילה קודם שישן. ומי שבחייו קודם שיפקיד נפשו ביד קונו העלה נשמתו מתוך פסוקי שמירה והגנה והשביע נפשו מדברי תורה ולן כמו כן יזכה בעת מיתתו כי יסייעוהו מן השמים לכוין דעתו לדברי קדושה ויסתלק מתוך עניינים ופוסקים של הצלה ורחמים ואז ילך לבטח דרכו: וישתדל החולה לקיים המצות שבכחו לקיים וישית לב לחלומותיו כמו שבא בפ׳ י״ד מאמר ב׳ בפרק כ״ג מאמר ה׳ כי משה בקש מחילה מישראל סמוך לפטירתו ומה יעשו אזובי קיר:[iii] עוד שם כי צריך הצדיק לקבל עליו המיתה ברצונו בסוד ושחט אותו וגומר:[iv] בפרק י״ט מאמר ה׳ בא מורה מקום מתחנות נאות שיאמר החולה אשר באו במעירי שחר של הרב המחבר נר״ו.[v] ומאמר

[from this world][1] amidst verses of mercy, if they merit it, and amidst contemplations of Torah. For this reason, a person's prayer during their lifetime for "a favorable time"—which refers to death—should be that they merit to sanctify [God's name] like the seraphim, as our Sages stated that one must be careful every night before sleeping [to recite the Shema]. And one who during their lifetime, before entrusting their soul into the hand of their Creator, has elevated their soul through verses of protection and defense, and has satisfied their soul with words of Torah, and sleeps accordingly, will merit at the time of their death that they will receive assistance from heaven to direct their mind to words of holiness,[2] and they will depart amidst matters and rulings concerning salvation and mercy, and then they will go securely on their way. The ill person should strive to fulfill the commandments that are within their power to fulfill, and should pay attention to their dreams, as is discussed in Chapter 14, Discourse 2, and in Chapter 23, Discourse 5, for Moses requested forgiveness from Israel just before his death—and what should mere "wall moss" [ordinary people] do?[3] It is also stated there that the righteous person must willingly accept death, in the mystical sense of "and he shall slaughter it," etc.[4] Chapter 19, Discourse 5 provides

[1]The Hebrew 'יסתלק' (yistaleck) is a euphemism for death that literally means 'to ascend/depart.' It carries connotations of elevation rather than mere cessation, reflecting the Jewish mystical view of death as a transition to a higher state.

[2]The Hebrew phrase 'לכוין דעתו לדברי קדושה' involves the concept of 'kavvanah' (focused intention), which is central to Jewish mystical practice. This suggests that the final moments of life are an opportunity for profound spiritual concentration and elevation.

[3]This rhetorical question employs a classic rabbinic formulation: if even the greatest (Moses) needed to do something, certainly ordinary people should do likewise. It's a 'kal vachomer' (a fortiori) argument common in rabbinic literature.

[4]The Hebrew 'בסוד' (b'sod) literally means 'in the secret of' and indicates a kabbalistic or mystical

[i]The term 'יזנוהו' (yaznuhu) is uncommon and seems to be related to being worthy or meriting something. In this context, it refers to being spiritually prepared to depart from the world while engaged with sacred texts.

[ii]This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the highest form of death is 'death by divine kiss' (mitat neshikah), where the soul joins the angelic chorus sanctifying God's name, similar to the seraphim in Isaiah's vision who call 'Holy, Holy, Holy.'

[iii]This is a rabbinic expression of humility, literally referring to hyssop growing from a wall—a small, insignificant plant compared to mighty cedars. The meaning is: if even Moses, the greatest prophet, needed to seek forgiveness before death, how much more so ordinary people?

[iv]This references Leviticus 1:5 regarding ritual sacrifice, drawing a kabbalistic parallel between the willing acceptance of death and the willingness of a sacrifice to be offered. The author suggests that death, like sacrifice, should be approached with intentional acceptance.

[v]Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) was a prayer collection compiled by the author of Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena. The abbreviation נר״ו (nero) means 'may his light shine' and is an honorific used for living scholars.

ראשון של זה הספר הוא טוב להקרא בפני כל חולה ובפרט פרק י״ז י״ח כ׳ וכ״א: [i]

guidance regarding appropriate prayers that the ill person should recite, which appear in the "Me'irei Shachar" [prayer collection] of the author, may his light shin[1]e. And the First Discourse of this book [Ma'avar Yabok] is good to be read before any ill person, especially Chapters 17, 18, 20, and 21. 3645R

במנחת אהרן[ii] מסודרים בקשות ופסוקים להרגיל האדם בהם שחרית ומנחה וערבית להרבות תחנונים: המנהג לסלק הקרובים מחדר הגוסס הוא דוקא כדי שלא לצערו בהרמת קולם אבל אם היו יכולים לעמוד על עמדם בלא דלויי קול אין ספק שיש תענוג לנפטר בהיות קרוביו החיים שם[iii] עיין בפרק כ״ח מאמר ה׳: עוד שם סוד ירושת האב. ורמז נשיאת בן לאב

In "Minchat Aharon"[2] [Aaron's Offering], requests and verses are organized for a person to recite habitually morning, afternoon, and evening to increase supplications. The custom of removing relatives from the room of a dying person is specifically to avoid causing distress through their raised voices, but if they were able to remain at their posts without raising their voices,[3] there is no doubt that the departing one finds pleasure in having living relatives present. See Chapter 28, Discourse 5. Also there is the mystery of paternal inheritance, and the symbolism of a son carrying his father on his shoulder, and likewise 3650R 3655R 3660R

interpretation rather than the plain meaning of the text. This reflects the author's approach of finding deeper mystical significances in biblical passages.

[1]This indicates that Aaron Berechia of Modena, the author of Ma'avar Yabok, also compiled a separate prayer collection called Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn), which contained prayers specifically designed for the sick and dying.

[2]Minchat Aharon (Aaron's Offering) appears to be another work by the author of Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena. The title creates a wordplay with the author's own name.

[3]The Hebrew phrase 'בלא דלויי קול' literally refers to raising or elevating the voice. The author is suggesting that if relatives could maintain emotional composure without loud crying or wailing, their presence could actually comfort the dying person.

[i]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage references multiple chapters and discourses within Ma'avar Yabok itself, showing how the author intended the book to be used as a reference guide with different sections serving specific purposes. The text explicitly directs readers to particular chapters for guidance on different aspects of preparing for death. | Cf. Kiddushin 72a (Talmud) — The reference to 'azovel kir' (wall moss/hyssop) alludes to a Talmudic expression of humility. In this context, it suggests that if even Moses, the greatest prophet, sought forgiveness before death, then ordinary people ('wall moss') certainly should do the same. | Cf. Leviticus 1:5 — The reference to 'and he shall slaughter it' draws a parallel between ritual sacrifice and death, suggesting that just as a sacrifice must be offered willingly and with proper intention, so too should a righteous person accept death willingly with the proper spiritual preparation. | Cf. Shema prayer tradition — The reference to being 'careful every night before sleeping' alludes to the Jewish practice of reciting the Shema before sleep, which includes entrusting one's soul to God. This practice is seen as a daily rehearsal for death, connecting daily spiritual practice to preparation for the final departure. | Cf. Isaiah 6:2-3 — The reference to sanctifying God's name like the seraphim alludes to Isaiah's vision where seraphim proclaim 'Holy, Holy, Holy.' This suggests that the ideal death involves the soul joining the angelic chorus in sanctifying God's name, creating a connection between the earthly deathbed and the heavenly throne room.

[ii]This appears to be another work by the same author (Aaron Berechia of Modena), which contains organized prayers to be recited at various times of day. The title 'Minchat Aharon' (Aaron's Offering) creates a wordplay with the author's own name.

[iii]This provides an important qualification to the Jewish practice of removing family from the deathbed. While the text acknowledges the custom of removing relatives to prevent emotional outbursts that might distress the dying person, it suggests that the quiet presence of family members can actually bring comfort to the departing soul.

על הכתף וכן תלמיד לרב.
ויש נייחא לאב שבניו יעסקו
בקבורתו: טעם עצימת הבן עיני
3430 אביו ולמה הבן קודם עיין פרק
ט׳ מאמר ג׳: עוד שם כי צריך
לכסות פני המת לבל יביטו
המקטרגים בפניו ובמצחו ששם
נרשמים העולות[i] ושם ג״כ כוונת
3435 הקריעה: עוד הרבה דיני קריעה
באו מפורשים בפרק ל״א מאמר
ה׳ ואז יאמרו:[ii]

a student for his teacher. And there is comfort for the father when his sons take care of his burial. The reason for the son closing his father's eyes, and why the son takes precedence, see Chapter 9, Discourse 3. Also there, it explains that one must cover the face of the deceased so that accusers [in heaven] will not look upon his face and forehead, where transgressions are recorded,[1] and this is also the intention behind the ritual tearing of garments.[2] Many more laws of ritual tearing are explained in Chapter 31, Discourse 5, and then they shall say: 3665R 3670R

יְיָ נָתַן וַיהוָה לָקָח יְהִי שֵׁם יְיָ
מְבוֹרָךְ: הַצּוּר תָּמִים פָּעֳלוֹ כִּי כָל
3440 דְּרָכָיו מִשְׁפָּט אֵל אֱמוּנָה וְאֵין עָוֶל
צַדִּיק וְיָשָׁר הוּא: וְהָלַךְ לְפָנֶיךָ
צִדְקֶךָ כְּבוֹד יְיָ יַאַסְפֶךָ: תִּשְׁכַּב
בְּשָׁלוֹם וְתִישַׁן בְּשָׁלוֹם[iii] עַד יָבוֹא
מְנֻחָם מַשְׁמִיעַ שָׁלוֹם:[iv v]

The LORD has given and the LORD has taken away;[3] blessed be the name of the LORD. The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are justice; a God of faithfulness without iniquity, righteous and upright is He. Your righteousness shall go before you; the glory of the LORD shall gather you in. You shall lie down in peace and sleep in peace[A] until the 3675R

[A] Or: "May you lie down in peace and sleep in peace" — While the Hebrew uses the future tense

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that a person's sins leave spiritual marks on the face and forehead that can be perceived by spiritual entities after death. This mystical concept explains several deathbed and burial practices.

[2] This refers to keriah, the Jewish practice of tearing one's garments upon learning of the death of a close relative. The text suggests this has a mystical significance beyond its expression of grief.

[3] This opening line from Job is among the most important biblical passages recited at Jewish funerals, acknowledging divine sovereignty over both life and death.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that spiritual prosecutors (מקטרגים/mekatregim) examine the deceased's face after death, where their transgressions are mystically recorded. Covering the face thus provides spiritual protection for the deceased.

[ii] Cf. Minchat Aharon — The author refers to his own prayer compilation 'Minchat Aharon' (Aaron's Offering), which appears to be a companion text to Ma'avar Yabok containing organized prayers for daily use. | Cf. Chapter 28, Discourse 5 — An internal cross-reference to another part of Ma'avar Yabok that discusses the presence of family members during death. | Cf. Chapter 9, Discourse 3 — An internal cross-reference to an earlier section of Ma'avar Yabok that explains the symbolism and procedure of a son closing his deceased father's eyes. | Cf. Chapter 31, Discourse 5 — An internal cross-reference to another section of Ma'avar Yabok that details the laws of keriah (ritual tearing of garments upon learning of a death).

[iii] The repetition of 'in peace' (בְּשָׁלוֹם) creates a poetic parallelism emphasizing the complete tranquility of the deceased's rest.

[iv] This phrase alludes to messianic expectations, suggesting that the deceased will rest peacefully until the time of resurrection.

[v] Cf. Book of Job 1:21 — This verse from Job is traditionally recited at Jewish funerals and during mourning. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this quote acknowledges divine sovereignty over life and death, affirming acceptance of God's will even in times of loss. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:4 — This verse affirms divine justice and righteousness even in the face of death, comforting mourners by reminding them that death occurs within God's perfect plan rather than being a random misfortune. | Cf. Isaiah 58:8 — In the context of death, this verse is reinterpreted to suggest that the deceased's righteousness will precede them in the afterlife, and God's presence will 'gather them in' to eternal rest. | Cf. Traditional Jewish burial prayer — The final line appears to be a comforting benediction not directly quoted from scripture but echoing biblical language, offering hope for the soul's peaceful rest until the messianic era when the comforter (possibly referring to Elijah or the Messiah) will come announcing peace.

comforter comes, proclaiming peace.[A] 3680R

בפרק ט׳ מאמר ג׳ כשמשימים
המת בקרקע יכוונו בי קרקע
עולם אינו מקבל טומאה[i] ואם
ינוחו המת במטה או על גבי
כלים הראויים לקבל טומאה
ב״ש שידרשו ויחזיקו בו
הרוחות:[ii] ויכסוהו בסדין
להעלימו מכחות הדין[iii] ואז
יאמרו:[iv]

In Chapter 9 of Discourse 3,[1] when placing the deceased on the ground, one should have the intention that the ground of the world does not receive ritual impurity.[B] If, however, they were to rest the deceased on a bed or upon vessels that are susceptible to ritual impurity, how much more so would the spirits seek out and take hold of the body.[C2] They should cover the deceased with a shroud to conceal them from the forces of judgment,[D] and then recite: 3685R

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב לְכוּ וְנֵלְכָה בְּאוֹר יְיָ׃ O house of Jacob, come and let us walk in the light 3690R

form, in this liturgical context it could be interpreted as a blessing or wish rather than a simple declaration, making 'May you' a potential alternative that captures the benedictory tone of the passage.

[A] Or: "until the Comforter arrives, announcing peace" — Capitalizing 'Comforter' would emphasize its possible messianic interpretation, and 'arrives, announcing' provides a slightly more formal alternative that might better match the solemn liturgical context.

[B] Or: "one should focus on the concept that earth itself cannot become ritually impure" — This more explanatory translation might be clearer to readers unfamiliar with the halakhic principle of 'karka olam' (ground of the world) and its relationship to ritual purity laws.

[C] Or: "negative spiritual entities will be drawn to and attach themselves to the body" — This alternate translation makes the negative nature of the 'ruchot' more explicit, clarifying that these are harmful spiritual forces rather than potentially neutral or positive spirits.

[D] Or: "from the powers of divine judgment" — The term 'kochot hadin' is a kabbalistic concept referring specifically to divine or cosmic judgmental forces, so this more explicit translation might be preferable in a context where the kabbalistic dimension needs to be emphasized.

[1] Ma'avar Yabok is organized into multiple 'ma'amarim' (discourses), each containing numerous chapters. This specific instruction comes from a chapter focused on proper burial procedures.

[2] This employs a common rabbinic logical device known as 'kal vachomer' (how much more so), inferring that if one undesirable outcome occurs in a lesser case, it will certainly occur in the greater case.

[i] This instruction reflects a halakhic principle found in rabbinic literature that land itself cannot become ritually impure, unlike movable objects. In Ma'avar Yabok, this principle takes on additional kabbalistic significance as protection for the soul.

[ii] The term 'ruchot' (spirits) here refers to negative spiritual entities that, according to kabbalistic belief, can attach themselves to the dead body. This concept appears frequently in the Zohar and other mystical texts, where proper burial practices are seen as essential for protecting the deceased from these harmful forces.

[iii] This reveals an important kabbalistic purpose behind the shroud beyond mere modesty—it serves as spiritual protection by concealing the deceased from 'kochot hadin' (forces of judgment), which are divine agencies of strict justice that might otherwise focus their attention on the deceased's transgressions.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2 — In Discourse 2, the author discusses similar concepts about how proper burial practices affect the soul's journey. This cross-reference helps establish the continuity of these ritual concepts throughout the work. | Cf. Zohar — The concepts about 'kochot hadin' (forces of judgment) and the protection of the deceased from harmful spiritual forces derive from Zoharic literature, which is the primary kabbalistic source for Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death rituals. | Cf. Talmud, Tractate Berakhot 8a — The Talmudic discussion about proper burial practices informs this text, particularly regarding the principle that prompt burial in the ground is preferable for the deceased's dignity and spiritual welfare.

3455 אֵל אֱלֹהִים יְיָ דִּבֶּר[i] וַיִּקְרָא אָרֶץ מִמִּזְרַח שֶׁמֶשׁ עַד מְבוֹאוֹ: יָבֹא שָׁלוֹם יָנוּחוּ עַל מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם הוֹלֵךְ נְכֹחוֹ:[ii] כִּי עָפָר אַתָּה וְאֶל עָפָר תָּשׁוּב: ג׳ פעמים[iii] [iv]

of the LORD.[1] God, the LORD God, has spoken and called the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting. Let peace come; let them rest upon their beds, those who walk uprightly. For dust you are, and to dust you shall return.[2] [three times][3] 3695R

3460 ואחר ששמוהו על גבי קרקע יאמרו עליו מזמור כ״ג ושיר של פגעים סימן צ״א[v] בחתוך מלותיו.[vi] טעם שהחמירו שמירה למתים[vii] הוא בפ׳ ל״ד מאמר

After placing him on the ground,[4] they should recite over him Psalm 23[5] and the "Song of Afflictions" (Psalm 91) with clear articulation of its words. The reason why they were strict about guarding the dead[6] is explained in Chapter 34, Discourse 2, and 3700R

[1]This begins a sequence of biblical verses to be recited during burial after placing the deceased on the ground. The progression moves from an invitation to walk in divine light to an acknowledgment of human mortality.

[2]This verse from Genesis 3:19 is traditionally recited during Jewish burial as earth is cast upon the coffin, acknowledging the physical reality of death while implicitly pointing to the spiritual continuation of the soul.

[3]The indication to repeat the final verse three times (׳ג פעמים) reflects the Jewish burial custom of casting earth upon the coffin three times, symbolizing the finality of physical death.

[4]This refers to the practice of placing the deceased on the ground before burial, which is part of the traditional Jewish burial preparation process. This is done after the washing and purification rituals (tahara) and before placing the body in the coffin.

[5]The well-known psalm beginning 'The Lord is my shepherd,' which contains themes of divine guidance, protection, and eternal dwelling with God—making it particularly appropriate in the context of death and burial.

[6]The Hebrew term for 'guarding' (shemirah) refers to the practice of having people stay with the deceased's body at all times from death until burial, which has both practical and spiritual significance in Jewish tradition.

[i]The threefold divine name ('El, Elohim, YHVH') appears in this order only here and in Joshua 22:22, emphasizing the full spectrum of divine attributes—from judgment to mercy—overseeing the moment of burial.

[ii]This verse from Isaiah 57:2 is traditionally understood as referring specifically to the righteous dead, suggesting that peaceful rest awaits those who have lived upright lives.

[iii]The instruction to repeat this verse three times corresponds to the custom of casting earth upon the coffin three times during burial.

[iv]Cf. Isaiah 2:5 — This opening verse from Isaiah calls the house of Jacob to walk in divine light, establishing a hopeful tone at the beginning of this funeral prayer sequence. | Cf. Psalm 50:1 — This psalm verse affirms God's universal sovereignty and authority, appropriate in the context of acknowledging divine judgment at death. | Cf. Isaiah 57:2 — This verse offers comfort regarding the peaceful rest of the righteous after death, a key theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a transition to spiritual rest. | Cf. Genesis 3:19 — This verse recalls God's statement to Adam after the Fall, acknowledging human mortality. In funeral contexts, it is often recited when earth is cast upon the coffin. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 19 of Third Discourse — This prayer appears in Ma'avar Yabok's instructions for what to recite after placing the deceased on the ground. The threefold repetition of 'For dust you are...' reflects the Jewish burial custom of casting earth three times upon the coffin.

[v]Psalm 91 is known in rabbinic tradition as 'Shir shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons) and was believed to have special protective properties against harmful spiritual forces.

[vi]This phrase indicates that the psalm should be recited with clear, precise articulation of each word, reflecting the belief that proper pronunciation was essential for the prayer's spiritual efficacy, especially in contexts related to protection from negative forces.

[vii]The practice of 'guarding the dead' (shemirat ha-met) refers to not leaving the body unattended between death and burial, which had both practical purposes and spiritual significance in protecting the deceased from harmful forces.

3465 ב׳ וטעם שפיכת המים[i] שם פ׳ כ״ג:[ii]

the reason for pouring water[1] is explained there in Chapter 23.

בפרק י״א מאמר ג׳ יש בו סדר רחיצת המת בפרטות על כל אבר ואבר אך כוונה זו שייכא בת״ח שהיה בחייו נרתק של קדושה[iii] דהא והא יגרום ליה חסדא:[iv][v]

In Chapter 11 of Discourse 3, there is a detailed order for washing the deceased,[2] addressing each individual limb. However, this intention is appropriate [only] for a Torah scholar who in his lifetime was a vessel of holiness,[3] as both this and that will cause him kindness.

3705R

בפרק י׳ מאמר ג׳ בעת שמזמנים עצמם לטהרו[vi] טוב שהגדול שבהם יאמר עליו תפלה זו בגין

In chapter 10, discourse 3, at the time when they prepare themselves to purify him[4] [the deceased], it is good for the eldest among them[5] to recite this

3710R

[1]This refers to a custom of pouring out all standing water in the vicinity of a death, which has various explanations in Jewish tradition related to purity, announcement of death, or protection from the Angel of Death.

[2]The Hebrew term 'seder rechitzat hamet' refers specifically to the ritual purification (tahara) performed by the burial society (Chevra Kadisha), which involves washing the body according to precise religious protocols.

[3]This is a kabbalistic concept suggesting that the body of a righteous person, particularly a Torah scholar, serves as a container for divine light and holiness during their lifetime. The ritualistic washing described in Chapter 11 is particularly appropriate for such individuals.

[4]The phrase refers to the tahara ritual, the washing and purification of the deceased's body prior to burial, performed by members of the Jewish burial society (Chevra Kadisha).

[5]The instruction that 'the eldest' or most senior member should lead the prayer reflects traditional Jewish hierarchy in ritual matters, where the most knowledgeable or respected individual takes a leadership role.

[i]The custom of pouring out water in a house where death occurred has multiple interpretations in Jewish tradition, including notifying neighbors of the death, symbolic purification, or removing the Angel of Death's influence.

[ii]Cf. Psalm 23 — This psalm, beginning 'The Lord is my shepherd,' is recited over the deceased as part of the burial ritual. Its themes of divine protection and guidance are especially appropriate for one transitioning from this world to the next. | Cf. Psalm 91 — Known as 'Shir shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons), this psalm was believed to have special protective powers against harmful spiritual forces. Its recitation at this stage of the burial process serves to protect the soul during its vulnerable transition. | Cf. Chapter 34, Discourse 2 — This cross-reference directs the reader to a section in Ma'avar Yabok that explains the theological and mystical reasons for guarding the dead, likely related to protecting the body from harmful spiritual forces during the vulnerable period after death. | Cf. Chapter 23 — This reference points to another section in Ma'avar Yabok that explains the practice of pouring water after a death, which likely relates to purification and symbolic separation between the living and the dead.

[iii]This phrase literally means 'sheath/vessel of holiness' and is a kabbalistic concept referring to someone whose body served as a worthy container for divine light and Torah knowledge during their lifetime. It suggests that special ritual attention is appropriate for those who achieved this spiritual status.

[iv]This Aramaic phrase translates approximately as 'for this and that will cause him kindness.' It suggests that the detailed ritual washing and the proper intentions behind it will provide spiritual benefit to the deceased Torah scholar.

[v]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage refers to another section of the same book (Ma'avar Yabok) that contains detailed instructions for the ritual washing (tahara) of the deceased. The cross-reference reveals the book's internal organization, with specific guidance located in particular chapters. | Cf. Zohar — The phrase 'vessel of holiness' (נרתק של קדושה) is reminiscent of Zoharic terminology, where the body is described as a vessel or sheath for the soul. This kabbalistic concept influences the author's approach to the ritual purification of the deceased.

[vi]This refers to the ritual purification (tahara) performed on the deceased body before burial, a sacred duty carried out by the burial society (Chevra Kadisha).

דיתרבי ויתוסף רבות קדושה באתר דאצטריך[i] ויכוין לעורר הרחמים:[iii] [ii]

prayer over him, in order that holiness may increase and be added in the place where it is needed,[1] and he should intend to arouse mercy:

[iv] תפלה לאומרה בשעת רחיצה

Prayer to be Recited during the Washing [of the Deceased][A] 3715R

רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם חֲמוֹל עַל פְּלוֹנִי בֶּן פְּלוֹנִית[v] הַמֵּת הַלָּז שֶׁהוּא בֶּן אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק וְיַעֲקֹב עֲבָדֶיךָ וְתָנוּחַ נַפְשׁוֹ וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ עִם הַצַּדִּיקִים כִּי אַתָּה מְחַיֶּה הַמֵּתִים. וּמֵמִית חַיִּים.[vi] בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה מוֹחֵל וְסוֹלֵחַ לַחֲטָאִים וְלַעֲוֹנוֹת מְמֹתֵי עַמָּךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּתַחֲנוּנִים: וּבְכֵן יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתְּסַבֵּב מַלְאֲכֵי רַחֲמִים לְפָנֵי הַמֵּת שֶׁהוּא עַבְדְּךָ

Master of the Universe,[2] have mercy upon [name] son of [mother's name], this deceased one who is a son of Your servants Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. May his soul and spirit rest with the righteous, for You give life to the dead and cause the living to die. Blessed are You who pardons and forgives the sins and iniquities of the dead of Your people Israel through supplications. And so, may it be Your will, Lord our God and God of our fathers, that You direct angels of mercy before this deceased one who is Your servant, son of Your handmaid.[3] And You, Lord our 3720R 3725R

[A] Or: "Prayer to be Recited at the Time of Washing" — This translation is slightly more literal but doesn't explicitly indicate that this refers to the ritual washing of a deceased person (tahara), which would be clear from context to the original audience.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic worldview of Ma'avar Yabok, where ritual acts in the physical world create corresponding spiritual effects in higher realms. The purification ritual isn't merely physical cleansing but a mystical act that affects the soul's journey.

[2] The opening phrase 'רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם' (Ribbono shel Olam) is a traditional form of address to God that emphasizes His sovereignty over creation. This mode of address is particularly appropriate in prayers concerning death, where divine sovereignty over life and death is acknowledged.

[3] The formulation 'Your servant, son of Your handmaid' (עַבְדְּךָ בֶּן אֲמָתֶךָ) emphasizes the deceased's relationship to God as both an individual servant and as coming from a lineage of divine service, creating multiple bonds of connection that justify the request for mercy.

[i] This Aramaic phrase reflects the kabbalistic understanding that ritual actions have corresponding effects in higher spiritual realms. The purification of the body is understood to facilitate the purification of the soul in the celestial domains.

[ii] In kabbalistic practice, proper intention (kavvanah) is essential for ritual efficacy. Here, the focus should be specifically on arousing divine mercy for the soul of the deceased.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This citation refers to a specific section of Ma'avar Yabok where instructions for the tahara ritual (purification of the deceased) are provided. The author is indicating where in the larger work this liturgical guidance can be found. | Cf. Zohar — The Aramaic phrases 'בגין דיתרבי ויתוסף רבות קדושה באתר דאצטריך' (in order that holiness may increase and be added in the place where it is needed) echo the language and mystical concepts found in the Zohar, where ritual actions are understood to have metaphysical effects in higher spiritual realms.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This prayer appears in the section of Ma'avar Yabok that deals specifically with tahara (ritual washing of the deceased). The prayer is designed to be recited by the leader of the burial society while performing the purification ritual, to invoke divine mercy for the deceased's soul. | Cf. Zohar — The prayer's references to divine attributes flowing to the deceased's soul reflect Zoharic concepts of channeling divine energies through ritual actions. The Idra Rabba section of the Zohar discusses how divine attributes flow through cosmic channels, which this prayer seeks to activate through the ritual washing.

[v] These placeholder names would be replaced with the actual name of the deceased and his mother's name during the ritual. The use of the mother's name rather than the father's name in prayers for the dead is a common Jewish practice.

[vi] This theological statement—'You give life to the dead and cause the living to die'—reflects the Jewish understanding of God's absolute sovereignty over life and death, which is particularly relevant in this funerary context.

בֶּן אֲמָתֶךָ: וְאַתָּה יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ
וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ מַשְׂכִּיל אֶל דָּל
מַלְּטֵהוּ מִכָּל צָרָה וּמִיּוֹם רָעָה
וּמִדִּינַת שֶׁל גֵּיהִנָּם: בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה
3495 גּוֹדֵל הַחֶסֶד וּבַעַל הָרַחֲמִים:
בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה הָעוֹשֶׂה שָׁלוֹם
בִּמְרוֹמָיו לַעֲבָדָיו וּלְיִרְאָה שְׁמוֹ:
בָּרוּךְ פּוֹדֶה עַמּוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל מִמִּינֵי
פּוּרְעָנִיּוֹת בְּרַחֲמִים: וּבְכֵן יְהִי
3500 רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי
אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתִּזְכֹּר זְכוּת בְּרִית
קוֹדֶשׁ שֶׁבְּבְשָׂרוֹ[i] וְיִהְיֶה פִּדְיוֹן לוֹ
מִשְּׁרַפַת גֵּיהִנָּם וְתַחֲלִיצֵהוּ. בָּרוּךְ
אַתָּה כּוֹרֵת הַבְּרִית בְּרַחֲמִים: ב'
3505 פְּעָמִים וְיוֹסִיף וְיֹאמַר:[ii] בְּרַחֲמִים
הַסְתֵּר וְהַעְלֵם פִּשְׁעֵי חֲמַת הַזֶּה
עַבְדֶּךָ מִשְּׂרַפַת אֵשׁ תַּחֲלִיצֵהוּ
שֶׁהוּא צְרִיךְ לְרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים:
וְאַתָּה יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ טוֹב וְסַלָּח
3510 לְכָל קוֹרְאֶיךָ. בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה גּוֹדֵל
הָעֵצָה וְרַב הָעֲלִילָיָה בְּרַחֲמִים עִם
רַגְלֵי צַדִּיקִים בְּגַן עֵדֶן יִדְרוֹךְ כִּי
מָקוֹם יְשָׁרִים[iii] הוּא רַגְלֵי חֲסִידָיו
יִשְׁמוֹר: בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה חַנּוֹתֵן רַחֲמִים
3515 גְּדוֹלִים וְרַב תַּחֲנוּנִים לְמֵתֵי עַמּוֹ
יִשְׂרָאֵל אָמֵן כֵּן יְהִי רָצוֹן:[iv]

God and God of our fathers, who considers the poor, deliver him[1] from all distress, from the day of evil, and from the judgment of Gehenna. Blessed are You, 3730R
great in kindness and Master of mercies. Blessed are You who makes peace in His heights for His servants and for those who fear His name. Blessed is He who redeems His people Israel from all kinds of calamities with compassion. And so, may it be Your will, Lord 3735R
our God and God of our fathers, that You remember the merit of the holy covenant in his flesh, and may it be a redemption for him from the burning of Gehenna,[2] and rescue him. Blessed are You who establishes the covenant with mercy. [Say twice and 3740R
add:] With mercy, hide and conceal the transgressions of this deceased one, Your servant; rescue him from the burning fire, for he needs Your abundant mercy. And You, Lord our God, are good and forgiving to all who call upon You.[3] Blessed are You, 3745R
great in counsel and mighty in deed, with mercy; may he tread with the feet of the righteous in the Garden of Eden, for it is the place of the upright; He guards the feet of His faithful ones. Blessed are You who grants great mercies and abundant supplications to 3750R
the dead of His people Israel. Amen, so may it be His will.

[1]The phrase 'מַשְׂכִּיל אֶל דָּל' (maskil el dal) comes from Psalm 41:2, where considering the poor is linked to divine deliverance in times of trouble. Here it is applied metaphorically to the deceased as one in need of divine consideration and deliverance.

[2]The Hebrew verb 'תַּחֲלִיצֵהוּ' (tachaliẓehu) has connotations of both rescuing and strengthening. In this context, it refers to divine intervention that both rescues the soul from punishment and strengthens it for its journey in the afterlife.

[3]This phrasing echoes Psalm 86:5, connecting this funeral prayer to the biblical tradition of appealing to God's inherent qualities of goodness and forgiveness as the basis for requesting mercy.

[i]This refers to the covenant of circumcision (brit milah). In kabbalistic thought, circumcision is believed to provide spiritual protection that extends beyond death, potentially shielding the soul from punishment in Gehenna.

[ii]This instruction indicates that the previous blessing ('Blessed are You who establishes the covenant with mercy') should be recited twice, and then the prayer continues with the additional words that follow.

[iii]The phrase 'place of the upright' describes the Garden of Eden as the destination for righteous souls. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theme that proper ritual observance in life leads to a favorable afterlife destination.

[iv]Cf. 1 Samuel 2:9 — This biblical verse is incorporated into the prayer as an assurance that God protects the righteous even in death. In Ma'avar Yabok, this reference supports the theological concept that divine protection continues beyond death, with the deceased's soul being guided safely through its post-mortem journey. | Cf. Covenant of Circumcision (Brit Milah) — This references circumcision as a protecting merit for the deceased. In Jewish mystical thought, particularly as expressed in Ma'avar Yabok, the covenant of circumcision serves as a spiritual protection that extends beyond death, shielding the soul from punishment in the afterlife. | Cf. Genesis 24:65 — This formulation echoes biblical language where lineage is sometimes traced through the mother. In

בסדר התפלה הזאת יש בה תקון
מיוחס לרחיצת כל אחד מאברי
המת[i] לראש בפני עצמו ולעינים
ולפנים ולזקן וכן כל אבר ואבר
ממעלה למטה ולכן לא הזכיר
מלת רחמים רק מו הראש ולמטה
כי משם ולמטה מתראי׳ הדילים
למעלה בצלם העליון[ii] וצריך
להתחיל בטהרתו מן הראש
ובסדר הזה ילך ממעלה למטה
ואם יכוונו ברחיצתו בפסוקי
שיר השירים שנרמז בהם סדר
הקומה השלימה[iii] המתחילים
ראשו כתם פז וגו׳:[iv]

In this prayer order,[1] there is a specific correction[A] dedicated to the washing of each part of the deceased's body: for the head separately, for the eyes, the face, the beard, and so for each limb from top to bottom. This is why the word "mercy" (rachamim) is mentioned only from the head downward,[2] because from there and below the weak aspects are visible[B] above in the supernal image.[C] One must begin the purification from the head, and in this order proceed from top to bottom. If they focus their intention during the washing on the verses from Song of Songs that allude to the order of the complete divine structure,[D] beginning with "His head is finest gold, etc."

[A] Or: "ritual procedure attributed" — The term 'תקון' in kabbalistic contexts often refers to a ritual procedure or spiritual rectification rather than a 'correction.' 'מיוחס' can mean 'attributed to' or 'associated with' rather than just 'specific.'

[B] Or: "the corresponding aspects manifest" — This phrase is obscure in the original and might be referring to corresponding spiritual elements rather than 'weak aspects.' The word 'דילים' is unusual and my translation is approximate.

[C] Or: "in the divine image above" — This could be more explicitly translated to emphasize the divine nature of the image referred to in kabbalistic thought.

[D] Or: "the arrangement of the complete stature" — 'קומה השלימה' is a kabbalistic concept referring to the complete spiritual 'stature' or structure of divinity. My original translation adds 'divine' for clarity, but a more literal translation might be preferred.

[1] The Hebrew term 'סדר התפלה' refers to the structured liturgical sequence being described in Ma'avar Yabok for the ritual washing of the deceased.

[2] The text is explaining why certain words or formulations appear in the prayer sequence at particular points, connecting the physical ritual with mystical significance.

the context of this prayer, it emphasizes the deceased's complete belonging to God's household, as both a servant himself and the child of one who serves God. | Cf. Jeremiah 32:19 — This phrase is drawn from Jeremiah, where it appears in a context praising God's wisdom and power. In Ma'avar Yabok's funeral prayer, it serves to invoke these divine attributes specifically for mercy toward the deceased, suggesting that God's great wisdom includes knowing how to judge the dead with compassion. | Cf. Garden of Eden (Gan Eden) — This references the Jewish concept of the Garden of Eden as the place where righteous souls dwell after death. In Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, this represents the highest reward for the deceased—being counted among the righteous and dwelling in divine presence.

[i] This refers to the tahara ritual, the Jewish practice of washing the deceased's body before burial. The text explains that this ritual has specific spiritual significance for each body part.

[ii] This phrase contains obscure terminology but appears to refer to the kabbalistic concept that the human body mirrors the divine structure, with lower aspects corresponding to higher spiritual attributes.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic interpretation of Song of Songs 5:11-16, which describes the beloved's body from head to foot. In mystical tradition, these verses are understood as describing the divine structure (Shi'ur Komah) and the sefirot (divine emanations).

[iv] Cf. Song of Songs — The text references verses from Song of Songs that describe the physical attributes of the beloved, particularly beginning with 'His head is finest gold' (5:11). In kabbalistic tradition, these verses are interpreted as describing the divine structure (Shi'ur Komah), and are applied here as a meditation during the ritual washing of the deceased's body, creating a correspondence between human and divine form. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage appears to be elaborating on the tahara (ritual washing) procedures described earlier in Ma'avar Yabok. It specifically provides mystical intentions (kavvanot) to accompany the physical act of washing,

רֹאשׁוֹ כֶּתֶם פָּז קְוֻצּוֹתָיו תַּלְתַּלִּים
שְׁחֹרוֹת כָּעוֹרֵב: עֵינָיו כְּיוֹנִים
עַל אֲפִיקֵי מָיִם רֹחֲצוֹת בֶּחָלָב
יֹשְׁבוֹת עַל מִלֵּאת: לְחָיָו כַּעֲרוּגַת
3535 הַבֹּשֶׂם מִגְדְּלוֹת מֶרְקָחִים שִׂפְתוֹתָיו
שׁוֹשַׁנִּים נֹטְפוֹת מוֹר עֹבֵר: יָדָיו
גְּלִילֵי זָהָב מְמֻלָּאִים בַּתַּרְשִׁישׁ
מֵעָיו עֶשֶׁת שֵׁן מְעֻלֶּפֶת סַפִּירִים:
שׁוֹקָיו עַמּוּדֵי שֵׁשׁ מְיֻסָּדִים עַל
3540 אַדְנֵי פָז מַרְאֵהוּ כַּלְּבָנוֹן בָּחוּר
כָּאֲרָזִים: חִכּוֹ מַמְתַקִּים וְכֻלּוֹ
מַחֲמַדִּים[i] זֶה דוֹדִי וְזֶה רֵעִי בְּנוֹת
יְרוּשָׁלָם:[ii]

His head is like the finest gold, his locks are wavy, black as a raven. His eyes are like doves by streams of water, bathed in milk, sitting by pools. His cheeks are like a bed of spices, towers of perfumes. His 3770R
lips are lilies, dripping liquid myrrh. His hands are rods of gold set with beryl, his body is polished ivory decorated with sapphires. His legs are pillars of marble set on bases of fine gold. His appearance is like Lebanon, choice as the cedars.[A] His mouth 3775R
is sweetness itself; he is altogether desirable. This is my beloved, and this is my friend, O daughters of Jerusalem.

וכן יכוונו בהרחצת כל אבר
3545 מכוון לאותו שנזכר בפסוק הנה
מה טוב[iii] ובפרט אם הוא אדם
גדול וטוב שחבריו ותלמידיו

And they shall have intention during the washing of each limb corresponding to that which is mentioned 3780R
in the verse "How good and pleasant it is"[1] [Psalm 133:1], especially if he is a great person. And it is

[A] Or: "His appearance is like Lebanon, excellent as the cedars" — The Hebrew 'בָּחוּר' can be translated as 'choice,' 'excellent,' or 'select.' While 'choice' captures the sense of superiority and selectness, 'excellent' might better convey the majesty and grandeur that the comparison to Lebanon and cedars is meant to evoke in this context.

[1] This is the opening phrase of Psalm 133, which celebrates unity among people. In the context of tahara (ritual washing of the deceased), this suggests that each limb should be washed with specific spiritual intention, creating a harmony between the physical act and its spiritual significance.

suggesting that the practitioner should meditate on the correspondence between the human body and the divine structure while performing the ritual.

[i] This entire passage is from Song of Songs 5:11-16, which describes the beloved in elaborate, poetic terms. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this biblical text is recited during tahara (ritual washing of the deceased) as part of a mystical practice where specific verses are associated with different body parts. This practice reflects the kabbalistic concept that the human form mirrors divine structures, and by reciting these verses during purification, the body is dignified and the soul elevated.

[ii] Cf. Song of Songs (Shir HaShirim) 5:11-16 — This is a direct quote from the biblical Song of Songs, which is traditionally interpreted in Jewish mysticism as an allegory of the relationship between God and Israel or the relationship between the soul and the divine. In Ma'avar Yabok, this passage is being used in the context of ritual purification of the deceased, where specific verses from Song of Songs are recited or contemplated for different parts of the body during tahara (ritual washing). The passage describes the beloved in elaborate, poetic terms, using precious materials as metaphors for different body parts. In the context of death rituals, this recitation helps dignify the body of the deceased by connecting it to sacred text and divine imagery. | Cf. Zohar — The use of this Song of Songs passage in death rituals reflects kabbalistic practices influenced by the Zohar, where the human form is understood to mirror divine structures. By reciting these verses during the washing of the deceased, the ritual performers are creating a correspondence between the physical body and spiritual realms, helping to elevate the soul. The Zohar frequently interprets Song of Songs as depicting mystical unions between divine attributes.

[iii] The text is referring to washing each limb of the deceased's body with specific spiritual intention (kavvanah). The phrase "How good and pleasant it is" opens Psalm 133, which was understood in kabbalistic tradition to have mystical significance relating to unity and divine harmony. The instruction suggests that each part of the body should be washed with awareness of its corresponding spiritual counterpart.

יעסקו ברחיצתו[i] ובעשיית כל צרכיו כדחזינן ברבינו הקדוש ורשב״י ויעקב אבינו[ii] ושאר חסידים עליהם השלום:[iii]

good that his friends and disciples should engage in his washing and in performing all his needs, as we have seen with our holy Rabbi[1] [Judah the Prince], Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai,[2] our father Jacob, and other pious ones, peace be upon them.[3] 3785R

בפרק י״ב מאמר ג׳ יתבאר מיני בשמים הראויים להטיל במים של טהרה[iv] וכוונתם:[v] ובהסרת הסדין מעליו יאמרו:[vi]

In Chapter 12 of the Third Discourse,[4] the types of spices appropriate to place in the purification water and their spiritual intentions will be explained. And when removing the sheet from the deceased,[5] they shall recite: 3790R

[1] This refers to Rabbi Judah the Prince (also known as Rabbi Judah HaNasi or Rabbenu HaKadosh), who compiled the Mishnah in the 2nd century CE. According to tradition, his students were involved in his burial preparations.

[2] A 2nd-century Tannaic sage traditionally regarded as the author of the Zohar, the foundational work of Kabbalah. According to tradition, his disciples attended to his body after his death.

[3] This honorific phrase ("aleihem ha-shalom" in Hebrew) is traditionally added after mentioning deceased righteous individuals, similar to the English "may they rest in peace."

[4] The text uses the abbreviation פרק י״ב מאמר ג׳, a standard reference format in rabbinic literature indicating Chapter 12 of the Third Discourse.

[5] This instruction comes at a specific point in the tahara ritual when the sheet covering the deceased is removed before dressing the body in shrouds (tachrichim).

[i] This reflects the Jewish tradition that it is considered a special honor and final act of loving-kindness (chesed shel emet) for a person's closest associates to personally perform the tahara (ritual washing) for the deceased rather than leaving it to the general members of the burial society.

[ii] The text cites prestigious examples where disciples or family members performed burial preparations: Rabbi Judah the Prince (known as "Rabbeinu HaKadosh"), whose students prepared his body according to Talmudic accounts; Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai (Rashbi), whose disciples attended to him according to tradition; and the biblical patriarch Jacob, whose son Joseph arranged for his preparation for burial.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 133 — The reference to 'Behold how good and pleasant it is' comes from Psalm 133:1, which celebrates unity among brethren. In this context, it's being applied to the tahara ritual (washing of the deceased), suggesting that each limb of the body should be washed with specific intention, connecting the physical act to spiritual meaning. | Cf. Ketubot 103a — The reference to 'our holy Rabbi' (Judah the Prince) alludes to the Talmudic account in Ketubot 103a describing how Rabbi Judah the Prince's students cared for him during his final illness and after his death. | Cf. Zohar III:296b-297a — The reference to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai (Rashbi) seems to allude to the Zohar's account of his death, where his disciples attended to him and participated in his funeral arrangements. | Cf. Genesis 50:1-14 — The reference to 'Jacob our father' alludes to the biblical account in Genesis where Joseph himself tended to his father's body after death, including the Egyptian embalming process.

[iv] In the tahara ritual, specific aromatic substances are added to the purification water both for practical purposes (masking odors) and for spiritual reasons (symbolizing the pleasant fragrance of good deeds that accompany the soul).

[v] The term כוונתם (kavvanatam) refers to the specific mystical intentions and meditations that should accompany the physical action of adding spices to the water, reflecting the kabbalistic belief that proper intention transforms ritual actions into cosmic effects.

[vi] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is a self-reference within Ma'avar Yabok, directing readers to Chapter 12 of the Third Discourse where the author provides detailed information about the aromatic substances used in the tahara ritual (purification of the deceased) and their mystical significance. | Cf. Tahara ritual — The passage refers to the Jewish purification ritual (tahara) performed on the deceased before burial, which includes washing the body with water containing aromatic substances and removing the sheet covering the body at specific points in the ritual.

וַיַּעַן וַיֹּאמֶר אֶל הָעֹמְדִים לְפָנָיו לֵאמֹר[i] הָסִירוּ הַבְּגָדִים הַצֹּאִים מֵעָלָיו וַיֹּאמֶר אֵלָיו רְאֵה הֶעֱבַרְתִּי מֵעָלֶיךָ עֲוֹנֶךָ וְהַלְבֵּשׁ אֹתְךָ מַחֲלָצוֹת:[iii ii]

And he responded and said to those standing before him, saying: 'Remove the filthy garments[A] from him.' And he said to him: 'See, I have removed your iniquity from you,[1] and I will clothe you[2] with pure garments.'[B] 3795R

כִּי כְּשֶׁזּוֹרְקִין מַיִם עַל רֹאשׁוֹ.[iv] שָׁם מַתְחִילִין לְטַהֲרוֹ יֹאמַר הַגָּדוֹל שֶׁבָּהֶם וְהָעוֹמְדִים שָׁם יַעֲנוּ אַחֲרָיו:[vi v]

When they pour water over his head[3]—for there they begin to purify him—the eldest among them shall recite,[4] and those standing there shall respond after him: 3800R

מַעְיַן גַּנִּים בְּאֵר מַיִם חַיִּים

A fountain of gardens, a well of living waters, flowing

[A] Or: "the soiled garments" — The Hebrew 'tzo'im' literally refers to excrement or filth, but in a liturgical context, especially regarding burial practices, 'soiled' may be a more appropriate or dignified translation while still conveying the sense of impurity.

[B] Or: "festival garments" — The term 'machalatzot' in biblical Hebrew can specifically refer to festive or celebratory clothing, not just clean ones. In the context of ritual preparation for burial or the afterlife, this connotation of special ceremonial garments might be significant.

[1] The Hebrew employs the perfect tense ('he'evarti'/'I have removed'), creating a sense of completed action, emphasizing the definitive nature of spiritual purification that the ritual washing represents.

[2] The Hebrew shifts to what appears to be an infinitive construct form ('halbeish') rather than a clear future tense, which could be interpreted as either 'to clothe you' or '[I] will clothe you'. I've translated it as a future action to maintain the sequence of divine promise.

[3] The tahara (purification ritual) traditionally begins with washing the head first, as it's considered the most important part of the body, corresponding to the higher spiritual realms in Kabbalistic thought.

[4] The term 'הגדול שבהם' can refer either to the eldest person or to the most knowledgeable or respected member of the burial society performing the tahara ritual. Leadership in this sacred task is assigned based on wisdom and experience rather than merely chronological age.

[i] This verse from Zechariah 3:4 is recited when removing the deceased's clothing before the ritual washing (tahara). It creates a theological parallel between the removal of physical garments and the purification of the soul.

[ii] The term 'machalatzot' derives from the root meaning 'to withdraw' or 'remove' and refers to pure, clean garments that replace the soiled ones, symbolizing spiritual transformation. In Ma'avar Yabok's context of burial preparation, this represents the deceased's spiritual purification.

[iii] Cf. Zechariah 3:4 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this biblical verse is used in the context of preparing the deceased for burial, specifically when removing the deceased's clothes before ritual washing (tahara). The verse establishes a metaphorical connection between the physical removal of clothing and the spiritual removal of sin, suggesting that the tahara ritual has transformative spiritual effects beyond mere physical cleansing. | Cf. Mishnah Shabbat 23:5 — By invoking this biblical verse during the tahara ritual, Ma'avar Yabok connects the practical act of changing the deceased's garments to the ancient Temple service and priestly purification. This creates a spiritual framework where the burial society members (Chevra Kadisha) are performing a sacred purification ritual analogous to the priests preparing for divine service.

[iv] This refers to the beginning of the tahara ritual (ritual washing of the deceased), which follows a specific order starting with the head. In Kabbalistic thought, the head corresponds to the highest divine emanations.

[v] This call-and-response format creates a communal ritual action that is believed to be more spiritually powerful than individual recitation. The 'eldest' or most respected person leads, reflecting the hierarchical structure maintained even in ritual service to the deceased.

[vi] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage appears in the section of Ma'avar Yabok that provides detailed instructions for the tahara ritual (purification of the deceased's body). The book gives specific guidance on what prayers to recite at each stage of the ritual washing, integrating practical procedures with kabbalistic significance.

וְנֹזְלִים מִן לְבָנוֹן:[i] אִם רָחַץ יְיָ
אֶת צֹאַת בְּנוֹת צִיּוֹן וְאֶת דְּמֵי
יְרוּשָׁלַם יַדִּיחַ מִקִּרְבָּהּ בְּרוּחַ
מִשְׁפָּט וּבְרוּחַ בָּעַר:[ii] וְזָרַקְתִּי
3570 עֲלֵיכֶם מַיִם טְהוֹרִים וּטְהַרְתֶּם
מִכֹּל טֻמְאוֹתֵיכֶם וּמִכָּל גִּלּוּלֵיכֶם
אֲטַהֵר אֶתְכֶם:[iv iii]

from Lebanon.[A] When the Lord has washed away the filth of the daughters of Zion and cleansed the bloodstains of Jerusalem from its midst by a spirit 3805R
of judgment and by a spirit of burning.[B] And I will sprinkle clean water upon you, and you shall be clean; from all your impurities and from all your idols I will cleanse you.[1]

באמצע הרחיצה יאמר הגדול
שבהם[v] והאחרים יענו אחריו וכן
3575 בכל הסדר:[vii vi]

During the middle of the washing,[2] the eldest among 3810R
them[3] shall recite and the others shall respond after him, and so it shall be throughout the entire proce-

[A] Or: "A spring of gardens, a well of living waters streaming from Lebanon." — The Hebrew 'ma'ayan' could be translated as either 'fountain' or 'spring,' while 'nozlim' could be rendered as either 'flowing' or 'streaming.' This alternate translation maintains the meaning while using slightly different English vocabulary that some might find more poetic or natural.

[B] Or: "and by a spirit of purging fire" — The Hebrew 'ba'er' connotes burning specifically for purification purposes. The expanded translation 'purging fire' more explicitly conveys this sense of cleansing through fire, which is implied in the original Hebrew but might be missed in the more literal 'burning.'

[1] The use of first-person divine speech in this final verse is significant. While human hands perform the tahara ritual, the ultimate purification is understood to be performed by God. This reflects the Jewish theological principle that humans act as God's partners in sacred work.

[2] This refers specifically to the tahara, the ritual washing and purification of the deceased's body, which is a central element of traditional Jewish burial preparations.

[3] The Hebrew 'hagadol shebahem' could refer to the eldest person, but more likely refers to the most senior in knowledge, experience, or authority within the burial society.

[i] This verse from Song of Songs begins a sequence of biblical verses recited during the tahara ritual (washing of the deceased). The three verses together create a progression from the source of pure water (Lebanon) to the divine act of cleansing (the Lord washing away filth) to the promise of complete purification.

[ii] The 'spirit of judgment' and 'spirit of burning' have kabbalistic significance in Ma'avar Yabok, representing divine attributes that purify the soul. Physical washing symbolizes this spiritual purification process.

[iii] This collection of verses is recited specifically when pouring the nine measures of water (tisha kabin) over the body during tahara, considered equivalent to ritual immersion (tevilah) for the deceased.

[iv] Cf. Song of Songs 4:15 — In this context, the verse from Song of Songs is repurposed from its original romantic meaning to represent spiritual purification. The 'fountain of gardens' symbolizes the purifying waters used in the tahara ritual (washing of the deceased). | Cf. Isaiah 4:4 — This verse from Isaiah provides the theological foundation for the ritual washing, connecting physical purification with spiritual cleansing. In Ma'avar Yabok, it suggests that the tahara ritual is not merely physical but represents divine judgment and purification of the soul. | Cf. Ezekiel 36:25 — The verse from Ezekiel completes the spiritual framework by presenting purification as a divine act. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it suggests that while humans perform the physical tahara, the true spiritual cleansing comes from God, who removes impurities and prepares the soul for its journey.

[v] This refers to the most senior, knowledgeable, or respected member of the burial society (Chevra Kadisha) present at the tahara ritual, who is designated to lead the prayers and guide the procedure.

[vi] The term 'seder' (order/procedure) refers to the entire ritual washing process, which follows a carefully prescribed sequence of actions accompanied by specific prayers and biblical verses.

[vii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This instruction appears in the context of tahara (ritual washing of the deceased), which is extensively detailed throughout Ma'avar Yabok. The author provides specific liturgical instructions for this sacred ritual, emphasizing the communal nature of the

dure:[1]

מִקְוֵה יִשְׂרָאֵל מוֹשִׁיעוֹ בְּעֵת
צָרָה[i] לָמָּה תִּהְיֶה כְּגֵר בָּאָרֶץ
וּכְאוֹרֵחַ נָטָה לָלוּן: וְהִתְקַדִּשְׁתֶּם
וִהְיִיתֶם קְדֹשִׁים כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי
3580 יְיָ:[ii] כָּל כְּלִי יוּצַר עָלַיִךְ לֹא
יִצְלָח[iii] וְכָל לָשׁוֹן תָּקוּם אִתָּךְ
לַמִּשְׁפָּט תַּרְשִׁיעִי זֹאת נַחֲלַת עַבְדֵי
יְיָ וְצִדְקָתָם מֵאִתִּי נְאֻם יְיָ:
[iv]

O Hope of Israel, its savior in time of trouble,[2] why are You like a stranger in the land, and like a traveler who turns aside to lodge for a night? You shall sanctify yourselves and you shall be holy,[3] for I, the LORD, am holy. No weapon formed against you shall prosper, and every tongue that rises against you in judgment you shall condemn. This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD,[4] and their righteousness is from Me, declares the LORD. 3815R 3820R

ויאמר פסוק זה ג״פ:[vi v]

And he shall recite this verse three times:

[1]The Hebrew 'seder' (order/procedure) indicates that the washing ritual follows a prescribed sequence with specific prayers and actions, all following this call-and-response pattern.

[2]This passage is recited during the ritual washing of the deceased (tahara), creating a poignant context where the community appeals to God as the ultimate savior even in death, which is viewed as the ultimate "time of trouble."

[3]While the original biblical verse addressed the living, in Ma'avar Yabok this command is recited during the purification of the deceased, suggesting that the ritual washing continues the process of sanctification even after death.

[4]The passage concludes with divine assurance that righteousness comes from God, emphasizing that the deceased's ultimate judgment rests with divine mercy rather than human actions alone. This provides comfort to both the deceased's soul and the living who perform the tahara ritual.

practice with call-and-response elements led by the most senior person present. | Cf. Chevra Kadisha manuals — This instruction follows the format common in burial society (Chevra Kadisha) manuals, where specific roles are assigned to participants in ritual washing ceremonies. The designation of the 'eldest' or most senior person to lead prayers reflects the hierarchical structure typical in these sacred societies.

[i]The word "mikveh" (hope) creates a deliberate wordplay with the ritual bath (also called "mikveh") used for purification, suggesting that the ritual washing of the deceased connects them to God, Israel's true hope and salvation.

[ii]This verse from Leviticus, originally about ritual purity in life, is repurposed here to suggest that the tahara ritual spiritually sanctifies the deceased, preparing them for their return to the holy divine presence.

[iii]In the context of tahara, this verse takes on additional meaning as a form of spiritual protection for the deceased during their soul's journey, warding off negative forces that might attempt to prevent their peaceful transition.

[iv]Cf. Jeremiah 14:8 — The opening line is a direct quote from Jeremiah addressing God during a time of drought and distress. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse takes on additional meaning as it's recited during ritual purification of the deceased, suggesting that even in death, God remains Israel's hope and savior. | Cf. Leviticus 20:7 — This verse from Leviticus on ritual purity takes on deeper meaning in the context of tahara (ritual purification of the dead). It suggests that the ritual washing isn't merely physical but aims to restore spiritual purity to the deceased. | Cf. Isaiah 54:17 — This verse from Isaiah offers spiritual protection to the deceased, suggesting that no negative forces can harm the soul of one who has been properly prepared through ritual purification. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the soul's journey after death, this verse promises divine protection during that transition.

[v]This abbreviation stands for "gimmel pe'amim" meaning "three times." The threefold repetition of verses is common in Jewish liturgical practice, especially in rituals connected to protection or sanctification.

[vi]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is a standard liturgical instruction that appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok, directing the reader to repeat a specific verse three times. Such threefold repetitions are common in Jewish ritual practice, especially in contexts involving protection from negative spiritual forces or emphasizing particularly important biblical passages.

ושם בפרק הנ״ל[i] יתבאר טעם חפיפת הביצים[ii] על ראשו:[iii]

And in the same chapter mentioned above, the reason for rubbing eggs on his head will be explained. 3825R

בפרק י״ג מאמר ג׳ כוונת לבישת בגדיו[iv] על הסדר:[v] בעת עטיפת הטלית יאמרו הפסוק הכתוב לפנינו. וטוב שישימו הטלית על ראשו אם כך נוהג בחייו:[vi] וקשירת בגד הציצית למת עיין בפרק כ״ו מאמר ה׳:[vii]

In Chapter 13 of the Third Discourse, the intention for dressing the deceased in his garments according to the proper order[1] is explained: At the time of wrapping him in the prayer shawl, they should recite the verse written below.[2] And it is good to place the prayer shawl over his head if that was his custom during his lifetime. Regarding the tying of the ritual fringes garment[3] (tzitzit) on the deceased, see Chapter 26 of the Fifth Discourse. 3830R

נֵרְדְּ וְכַרְכֹּם קָנֶה וְקִנָּמוֹן עִם כָּל עֲצֵי לְבוֹנָה מֹר וַאֲהָלוֹת עִם כָּל

Nard and saffron, calamus and cinnamon, with all trees of frankincense, myrrh and aloes, with all the 3835R

[1]The concept of 'seder' (order) is significant in Jewish ritual, implying not just sequence but divine ordering. In burial preparation, this ordered dressing reflects cosmic harmony and respect for divine law.

[2]Interestingly, the verse mentioned is not actually included in this excerpt, suggesting this is part of a larger text where the verse appears immediately following this instruction.

[3]The question of whether a deceased should be buried wearing tzitzit (ritual fringes) has been debated in rabbinic literature, with various customs developing across different Jewish communities. This text acknowledges this complexity by referring the reader to a more detailed discussion elsewhere in the book.

[i]The text refers back to a previously mentioned chapter where this practice is explained in detail. This demonstrates the book's structure as a comprehensive reference guide for burial practices, with cross-references between sections.

[ii]This refers to the ritual practice of rubbing or rolling eggs on the head of the deceased during the tahara (purification) process. Eggs are symbolic in Jewish mourning rituals, representing the cycle of life and death, and are used in various purification contexts.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is a cross-reference to another section of Ma'avar Yabok where the author explains the ritual practice of rubbing eggs on the head of the deceased during the tahara (purification) process. This practice appears to be part of the ritual washing and preparation of the body.

[iv]The term 'kavvanat' (intention) indicates that the text is not merely describing physical actions, but also the proper spiritual focus or meditation that should accompany these ritual acts.

[v]The phrase 'al ha-seder' (according to the proper order) refers to the specific ritual sequence for dressing the deceased, indicating that there is a prescribed order for the garments that must be maintained for proper ritual preparation.

[vi]This instruction demonstrates an important principle in Jewish burial customs: maintaining the deceased's personal religious practices. The text specifically notes that how the tallit is positioned should reflect the individual's practice during life.

[vii]Cf. Chapter 13 of the Third Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — This passage explicitly references a specific chapter in Ma'avar Yabok that contains detailed instructions on the proper ritual dressing of the deceased, particularly regarding the significance of the prayer shawl (tallit). | Cf. Chapter 26 of the Fifth Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — This passage explicitly references another chapter in Ma'avar Yabok that contains instructions regarding the tying of ritual fringes (tzitzit) on the deceased, showing how the text provides cross-references to its own sections for more detailed guidance on specific aspects of burial preparation.

רָאשֵׁי בְשָׂמִים:[i][ii] finest spices.[1]

אחר שהלבישוהו[iii] יאמר לסוד לבישת בגדים הרוחניים:[iv][v] After they have dressed him,[2] they shall recite [the following] for the mystical significance of donning spiritual garments:[3] 3840R

3600 שׂוֹשׂ אָשִׂישׂ בַּיהוָה תָּגֵל נַפְשִׁי בֵּאלֹהַי[vi] כִּי הִלְבִּישַׁנִי בִּגְדֵי I will greatly rejoice in the LORD,[4] my soul shall exult in my God;[A] for He has clothed me with gar-

[A] Or: "my soul shall delight in my God" — The Hebrew verb 'tagel' (תָּגֵל) can be translated as

[4] The Hebrew רָאשֵׁי בְשָׂמִים literally means 'heads of spices' or 'chief spices,' referring to the most precious or principal aromatic substances. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's tahara ritual, these spices collectively represent the spiritual perfection that awaits the righteous in the afterlife.

[1] This refers to the ritual dressing of the deceased in burial shrouds (tachrichim) as part of the tahara (purification) process performed by the Jewish burial society (Chevra Kadisha).

[2] This phrase indicates that what follows is not merely a prayer but an explanation of the deeper kabbalistic meaning behind the physical act of clothing the deceased. In Jewish mystical thought, the soul is believed to wear 'garments' in the afterlife that correspond to one's Torah study, good deeds, and spiritual achievements in this world.

[3] This passage appears in Ma'avar Yabok as part of the ritual for dressing the deceased in shrouds (tachrichim). The joyful language of being clothed in salvation creates a powerful contrast with the somber act of preparing a body for burial, suggesting that death is a transition to spiritual elevation rather than merely an ending.

[viii] This verse is recited during the tahara ritual when dressing the deceased in shrouds. The aromatic substances mentioned symbolize spiritual purification and divine acceptance. Each spice is associated with different spiritual qualities in kabbalistic tradition, and their collective use represents the hope that the soul will be received in the Garden of Eden surrounded by spiritual fragrance.

[ix] Cf. Song of Songs 4:14 — This verse from Song of Songs is recited during the tahara ritual (ritual purification of the deceased) in Ma'avar Yabok. When dressing the deceased in shrouds, this verse is spoken to symbolically clothe the departed in spiritual fragrance and purity. In the original biblical context, the verse describes the beloved's body as a fragrant garden, but in this funeral context, it takes on additional meaning as a blessing that the deceased should be received in the Garden of Eden with all spiritual sweetness and purity.

[i] This instruction occurs within the tahara (ritual purification) process, specifically after the washing of the body and the dressing of the deceased in burial shrouds (tachrichim). The subsequent prayer establishes a theological connection between the physical shrouds and the spiritual garments the soul will wear in the World to Come.

[ii] The phrase 'for the mystical significance of donning spiritual garments' reflects the kabbalistic understanding in Ma'avar Yabok that ritual actions in this world create corresponding spiritual realities in higher worlds. The physical act of dressing the deceased is understood to have a parallel spiritual effect, clothing the soul in garments of salvation and righteousness for its journey in the afterlife.

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 61:10 — This verse is used in the context of dressing the deceased in shrouds, creating a parallel between physical burial garments and the spiritual garments that the soul will wear in the afterlife. The image of the bridegroom adorned with a garland and the bride adorned with jewels represents the soul's adorned state in the World to Come. | Cf. Zechariah 3:5 — This passage from Zechariah about placing a pure headdress on the High Priest Joshua symbolizes the spiritual purification of the deceased. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it represents the removal of sin and impurity as the soul transitions to the afterlife. | Cf. Isaiah 4:2 — This verse connects burial preparations to the broader theme of resurrection and renewal. The image of the earth bringing forth its growth parallels the soul's growth and flourishing in the World to Come after death. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — This verse is used to express hope for the deceased's soul—that it will be continuously guided by God, satisfied in spiritual abundance, and strengthened. The metaphor of becoming like a watered garden represents the soul flourishing in the divine presence after death.

[iv] This opening verse from Isaiah 61:10 introduces a passage about spiritual transformation represented through clothing metaphors. In the Jewish mystical tradition, the soul's transition after death is often depicted as a change of garments.

יֶשַׁע מְעִיל צְדָקָה יְעָטָנִי כֶּחָתָן
יְכַהֵן[v] פְּאֵר[i] וְכַכַּלָּה תַּעֲדֶה כֵלֶיהָ:
וָאֹמַר יָשִׂימוּ צָנִיף טָהוֹר עַל
3605 רֹאשׁוֹ[ii] וַיָּשִׂימוּ הַצָּנִיף הַטָּהוֹר עַל
רֹאשׁוֹ וַיַּלְבִּשֻׁהוּ בְּגָדִים וּמַלְאַךְ
יְיָ עֹמֵד: כִּי כָאָרֶץ תּוֹצִיא צִמְחָהּ
וּכְגִנָּה זְרוּעֶיהָ תַצְמִיחַ[iii] כֵּן יְיָ
אֱלֹהִים יַצְמִיחַ צְדָקָה וּתְהִלָּה נֶגֶד
3610 כָּל הַגּוֹיִם: וְנָחֲךָ יְיָ תָּמִיד וְהִשְׂבִּיעַ
בְּצַחֲצָחוֹת נַפְשֶׁךָ וְעַצְמוֹתֶיךָ
יַחֲלִיץ[iv] וְהָיִיתָ כְּגַן רָוֶה וּכְמוֹצָא
מַיִם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יְכַזְּבוּ מֵימָיו: [v]

ments of salvation, He has wrapped me with a robe of righteousness, as a bridegroom adorns himself with a garland,[A] and as a bride adorns herself with her 3845R
jewels. And I said, "Let them place a pure diadem upon his head." And they placed the pure diadem upon his head and clothed him with garments, while the angel of the LORD stood by.[1] For as the earth brings forth its growth, and as a garden causes its 3850R
seeds to sprout, so will the Lord God cause righteousness and praise to spring forth before all the nations.[2] And the LORD will guide you continually, and satisfy your soul in parched places, and strengthen your bones;[B] and you shall be like a wa- 3855R
tered garden, and like a spring of water whose waters never fail.[3]

either 'exult' or 'delight.' While 'exult' conveys the intensity of joy more strongly, 'delight' might be more accessible to modern readers.

[A]Or: "as a bridegroom priests himself with glory" — The Hebrew 'yekhahen' (יְכַהֵן) uses a priestly verb form that is difficult to render directly in English. This more literal translation preserves the priestly association but might be less clear to readers unfamiliar with this linguistic connection.

[B]Or: "and make your bones vigorous" — The Hebrew 'yachalitz' (יַחֲלִיץ) has connotations of liberation, invigoration, and strengthening. This alternate translation captures more of the sense of renewed vitality.

[1]The presence of the angel in this context symbolizes divine supervision of the soul's transition. In Jewish funeral practices, the body is traditionally not left alone before burial, mirroring this spiritual supervision on a physical level.

[2]In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this universal flourishing of righteousness connects to the concept that properly performed death rituals have cosmic significance, affecting not just the individual soul but contributing to the repair of the world (tikkun olam).

[3]This powerful image of perpetual nourishment serves in Ma'avar Yabok as a promise of continuous spiritual sustenance for the soul in the afterlife, providing comfort to both the deceased and the mourners.

[v]The verb 'yekhahen' (יְכַהֵן) derives from the same root as 'kohen' (priest), suggesting that the adorning has a sacred, priestly quality. This creates a connection between physical clothing and spiritual elevation.

[i]This verse from Zechariah 3:5 describes the purification of Joshua the High Priest. The 'pure diadem/turban' was part of the priestly garments and symbolized holiness and ritual purity.

[ii]The garden imagery here creates a metaphorical connection between physical growth and spiritual flourishing, a theme particularly relevant in the context of death and resurrection.

[iii]The strengthening of bones has particular significance in Jewish burial practices and beliefs about resurrection, as bones were considered the indestructible core from which the body would be rebuilt in the revival of the dead.

[iv]Cf. Isaiah 61:10-11 — This passage quotes directly from Isaiah 61:10-11, a text of comfort and restoration. In Ma'avar Yabok, it appears after the ritual washing and dressing of the deceased in shrouds, establishing a parallel between the physical preparation of the body and spiritual garments of salvation that await the soul in the afterlife. | Cf. Zechariah 3:5-6 — This reference quotes from Zechariah's vision of Joshua the High Priest being cleansed and reclothed, symbolizing purification from sin. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this connects the deceased's physical preparation (tahara) with spiritual purification of the soul. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — This final verse comes from Isaiah 58, describing God's promises to those who practice true righteousness including proper fasting and charity. In Ma'avar Yabok, it functions as a prayer for the soul's continual nourishment and flourishing in the afterlife.

בפרק י״ד מאמר ג׳ מתבאר כוונת שימת המת בארגז שהוא להטמין גופו מכח בעלי הדין[i] [ii] ואז יאמרו:

And in Chapter 14 of Discourse 3,[A] the intention behind placing the deceased in a coffin[B] is explained: it is to conceal the body from the forces of judgment.[C] At that moment, they shall recite:

וְלֹא יָבוֹאוּ לִרְאוֹת כְּבַלַּע אֶת הַקֹּדֶשׁ[iii] וָמֵתוּ:[iv] [v]

And they shall not come to see the holy things being swallowed up,[1] lest they die.[2]

[C] Or: "in Chapter 14 of the Third Discourse" — This alternative translation makes it clearer that this refers to a specific section of Ma'avar Yabok, using a more formal designation for the discourse number.

[D] Or: "the mystical purpose of placing the deceased in a coffin" — This alternative emphasizes the kabbalistic dimension implied by the term 'כוונת' (kavvanah/intention), which in this context refers to the spiritual significance behind the physical action rather than merely its practical purpose.

[A] Or: "to hide the body from the power of the prosecuting angels" — This translation more explicitly identifies 'בעלי הדין' as referring to prosecuting angels or negative spiritual forces in kabbalistic thought that might harm the deceased's soul.

[1] This is a direct quotation from Numbers 4:20, where the original context refers to the Kohathites being forbidden from viewing the covering of the sacred vessels of the Tabernacle. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is repurposed for burial rituals, drawing a parallel between the biblical sacred objects and the deceased's body, both requiring proper covering and respectful treatment.

[2] The severe consequence mentioned here (death) reflects the gravity with which both the biblical text and Ma'avar Yabok treat boundaries between sacred and profane. In the context of burial rituals, this verse emphasizes the sacred nature of the body and the spiritual importance of proper burial procedures.

[i] According to the kabbalistic worldview presented in Ma'avar Yabok, the deceased's body requires protection from spiritual forces that might harm the soul during its transition. The coffin serves as both physical container and spiritual shield against these 'forces of judgment' (בעלי הדין), which in Jewish mystical thought are angelic beings that prosecute the soul after death.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 14, Discourse 3 — This refers to an earlier section of the same book that contains a detailed explanation of why the body is placed in a coffin. According to kabbalistic thought presented in Ma'avar Yabok, the coffin serves as spiritual protection for the deceased's body, shielding it from negative spiritual forces (בעלי הדין) that might otherwise harm the soul during its transition. | Cf. Zohar, Vayechi — The Zohar in Parashat Vayechi discusses burial practices and the spiritual significance of the coffin, including how it protects the body. This section of Ma'avar Yabok likely draws on these Zoharic teachings.

[iii] This phrase literally means "when the holy things are swallowed up" or "as the holy is covered/concealed." In its original biblical context (Numbers 4:20), it refers to the covering of sacred vessels during transport to protect them from profane view. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is repurposed in the context of burial rituals, drawing a parallel between the biblical prohibition against viewing sacred objects being covered and the importance of properly covering/concealing the deceased's body.

[iv] The stark warning "lest they die" in the original biblical context established boundaries around sacred space. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's burial rituals, this verse is cited after the deceased has been placed in a coffin, suggesting a theological connection between proper treatment of the dead body and the biblical concept of sacred boundaries.

[v] Cf. Numbers 4:20 — Ma'avar Yabok applies this biblical verse to burial rituals, suggesting a parallel between the sacred objects of the Tabernacle and the deceased's body. Just as viewing the holy objects inappropriately could lead to death, improper treatment of the deceased's body has serious spiritual consequences. The verse is quoted immediately after instructions for placing the body in the coffin, emphasizing the importance of proper covering and treatment of the dead. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Emor — The use of this verse reflects the Kabbalistic concept that the human body, even after death, retains its sanctity as a vessel that once contained the divine soul. Just as the holy vessels of the Tabernacle required proper covering and handling, so too does the human body require respectful treatment in death. The parallel suggests that improper viewing or handling of the deceased constitutes a spiritual violation similar to inappropriately viewing the sacred Tabernacle vessels.

ואם הוא אדם חשוב[i] יאמרוהו ג׳ פעמים בקול רם:[ii]

And if he is an important person, they shall recite it three times[1] in a loud voice.

ואחר שכסוהו בארון[iii] יאמרו:[iv]

And after they have covered him in the coffin,[2] they shall say:

הִנֵּה מִטָּתוֹ שֶׁלִּשְׁלֹמֹה[v] שִׁשִּׁים גִּבֹּרִים סָבִיב לָהּ מִגִּבֹּרֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל: כֻּלָּם אֲחֻזֵי חֶרֶב מְלֻמְּדֵי מִלְחָמָה אִישׁ חַרְבּוֹ עַל יְרֵכוֹ מִפַּחַד בַּלֵּילוֹת:[vi] יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ: יָאֵר יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ: יִשָּׂא יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם:[vii] יִלְבְּלוּ יְנִקוֹתָיו וְיִהִי כַּזַּיִת הוֹדוֹ וְרֵיחַ לוֹ כַּלְּבָנוֹן:[viii] רָאִיתִי וְהִנֵּה מְנוֹרַת זָהָב כְּלָהּ וְגֻלָּהּ עַל רֹאשָׁהּ וְשִׁבְעָה נֵרֹתֶיהָ עָלֶיהָ שִׁבְעָה וְשִׁבְעָה מוּצָקוֹת לַנֵּרוֹת

Behold, Solomon's bed, which is surrounded by sixty valiant men[3] from the mighty warriors of Israel. All of them are skilled with the sword, trained in warfare, each with his sword upon his thigh because of fear in the nights. May the LORD bless you and keep you. May the LORD make His face shine upon you and be gracious to you. May the LORD lift up His countenance upon you[4] and give you peace. His shoots shall spread forth, and his splendor shall be like the olive tree,[5] and his fragrance like Lebanon. I looked, and behold a menorah of gold, all of it, with a bowl on its top, and seven lamps upon it, seven and seven

[1]The repetition of sacred formulas three times is a common practice in Jewish ritual, believed to strengthen their efficacy. This reflects the special honor accorded to religious leaders or community figures even after death.

[2]The Hebrew word 'aron' literally means 'ark' or 'chest' but in this context refers specifically to the coffin in which the deceased is placed. This section continues the meticulous sequence of prayers prescribed by Ma'avar Yabok for each stage of the burial preparation process.

[3]The original employs the term 'gibborim' (mighty ones), which has both military and spiritual connotations in Hebrew, suggesting not merely physical strength but spiritual power as well.

[4]The Priestly Blessing forms a central liturgical element in Jewish ritual. Its inclusion in burial contexts represents an adaptation from its original Temple and synagogue usage to provide spiritual protection for the deceased.

[5]The olive tree imagery carries rich symbolic meaning in Jewish tradition, representing fertility, longevity, and resilience—all qualities hoped for in the spiritual afterlife of the deceased.

[vi]This refers to a person of importance, likely a Torah scholar, community leader, or someone of high spiritual or communal standing.

[i]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The text shows special ritual considerations for people of high status, a common theme throughout Jewish burial practices. The instruction to repeat the verse three times for important individuals suggests that repetition was seen as intensifying the spiritual protection or honor accorded to the deceased.

[ii]This section provides instructions for what prayers to recite after the deceased has been placed in the coffin, continuing the sequence of ritual actions during Jewish burial preparations.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 14, Discourse 3 — This earlier section of Ma'avar Yabok likely contains the kabbalistic explanations for why the deceased is placed in a coffin and the spiritual meaning of this action, explaining how it protects the soul from negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:7-8 — The subsequent biblical quote about 'Solomon's bed' surrounded by sixty mighty warriors is interpreted as a metaphor for the coffin that protects the deceased, with the warriors representing spiritual protections against harmful forces during the soul's journey.

[iv]This reference to 'Solomon's bed' (from Song of Songs 3:7-8) is used metaphorically in the context of Ma'avar Yabok to represent the coffin of the deceased. The sixty valiant warriors symbolize protective angels or divine forces that guard the soul during its transition.

[v]The phrase 'fear in the nights' refers to spiritual dangers that might threaten the soul after death. In the context of burial rituals, this verse is recited to invoke divine protection against these forces.

[vi]The inclusion of the Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26) in burial rituals reflects the belief that the deceased requires divine blessing, protection, and peace during the soul's journey after death.

[vii]This verse from Hosea 14:7 is included to express the hope that the deceased's memory and spiritual legacy will continue to spread like a pleasant fragrance, even after death.

3635 אֲשֶׁר עַל רֹאשָׁהּ: וּשְׁנַיִם זֵיתִים עָלֶיהָ אֶחָד מִימִין הַגֻּלָּה וְאֶחָד עַל־שְׂמֹאלָהּ:[ii] [i]

spouts[1] for the lamps which are on its top. And two olive trees beside it, one on the right of the bowl, and one on its left. 3880R

אח״כ יאמרו בשבח הכבוד העליון ובזה דובב שפתי
3640 ישנים[iii] כדאמרו בבכורות פרק ה׳:[iv]

After that, they shall recite in praise of the Supreme Glory, and in this way "cause the lips of those who sleep to speak," as stated in Bechorot, chapter 5:[2] 3885R

אַתָּה הַר הַגָּדוֹל לִפְנֵי זְרֻבָּבֶל לְמִישֹׁר וְהוֹצִיא אֶת הָאֶבֶן רֹאשָׁה
תְּשֻׁאוֹת חֵן חֵן לָהּ:[v] וְעַתָּה יִגְדַּל
3645 נָא כֹּחַ אֲדֹנָי כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבַּרְתָּ לֵאמֹר:
וְאוּלָם חַי אָנִי וְיִמָּלֵא כְּבוֹד יְיָ אֶת

Who art thou, O great mountain?[3] Before Zerubbabel thou shalt become a plain; and he shall bring forth the headstone with shoutings of "Grace, grace unto it." And now, let the power of the Lord be great, according as Thou hast spoken, saying. But 3890R

[6]This unusual construction in the original Hebrew has been the subject of much rabbinic commentary. I've preserved the literal wording rather than smoothing it to 'fourteen spouts' to maintain its mystical significance related to the sevenfold divine attributes.

[1]This is a reference to a Talmudic teaching from Bechorot 31b that when a deceased person's teachings or words are quoted after their death, it brings merit to them in the afterlife, as if their lips continue to move in the grave. This concept is based on an interpretation of Song of Songs 7:10. Within the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that reciting these prayers not only aids the soul of the recently deceased but also brings merit to previous scholars and sages.

[2]The 'great mountain' in this funerary context symbolizes the obstacles facing the soul in its journey after death. The original passage in Zechariah referred to obstacles in rebuilding the Temple, but has been repurposed here to address spiritual barriers.

[i]This vision of the golden menorah and olive trees from Zechariah 4:2-3 represents divine light and continuous spiritual nourishment. In the context of burial rituals, it symbolizes the hope that the deceased's soul will be sustained by divine light in the afterlife.

[ii]Cf. Song of Songs 3:7-8 — This text from Song of Songs is recontextualized in Ma'avar Yabok as a burial prayer. While originally describing King Solomon's protected palanquin, here it symbolizes divine protection for the deceased's coffin and soul during its transition to the afterlife. | Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — The Priestly Blessing, originally given to Aaron and his sons to bless the people of Israel, is adapted here for burial rituals to invoke divine protection for the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Hosea 14:7 — This prophetic text, originally describing Israel's future restoration, is repurposed in burial contexts to express hope for the deceased's continued spiritual flourishing in the afterlife. | Cf. Zechariah 4:2-3 — Zechariah's vision of the menorah and olive trees, originally representing God's provision for the rebuilding of the Temple, is reinterpreted here as symbolizing divine light and spiritual sustenance for the soul in the afterlife.

[iii]The phrase 'dovev siftei yeshenim' (causing the lips of those who sleep to speak) reflects the rabbinic belief that when someone's teachings are cited after their death, it brings merit to the deceased in the afterlife. In Ma'avar Yabok, this note indicates that the following prayers in praise of the Supreme Glory are meant not only to assist the soul of the deceased but also to honor previous scholars and sages whose teachings are being recited.

[iv]Cf. Bechorot, Chapter 5 — The text references the Talmudic tractate Bechorot, chapter 5, which contains the phrase 'causing the lips of those who sleep to speak' (dovev siftei yeshenim). This phrase appears in the context of discussing how reciting teachings in the name of a deceased scholar brings merit to them in the afterlife, as if their lips continue to move in the grave. | Cf. Song of Songs 7:10 — The phrase 'dovev siftei yeshenim' (causing the lips of those who sleep to speak) comes from Song of Songs 7:10, which reads 'Your palate is like the best wine that goes down smoothly for my beloved, moving gently the lips of sleepers.' In rabbinic interpretation, this verse was understood to mean that when someone's teachings are repeated after their death, it's as if their lips continue to move in the grave, bringing them merit in the afterlife.

[v]The repetition of the word 'grace' (חן חן) emphasizes the divine favor requested for the soul's journey. This comes from Zechariah 4:7 where it refers to the Temple's cornerstone, but in this deathbed context, it refers to the soul as a precious stone being elevated to the divine realm.

כָּל הָאָרֶץ׃ [i]

as truly as I live, and as all the earth shall be filled with the glory of the LORD.[1]

וטוב לעשות צרכי ת״ח [ii] במקום שעסק שם בתורה בחייו יעויין שם הטעם׃ [iii] טעם שאין להלין המת ולא להסתכל בפניו עין בפרק כ׳ מאמר ב׳׃ סוד לויית המת [iv] יתבאר בפרק כ׳ וכ״ו מאמר ב׳׃ [v]

It is good to attend to the needs of a Torah scholar in the place where he engaged in Torah study during his lifetime; the reason for this can be found there. The reason why one should not delay the burial of the deceased or gaze at his face can be found in Chapter 20 of the Second Discourse. The secret meaning of accompanying the deceased [in funeral procession] will be explained in Chapter 20 and Chapter 26 of the Second Discourse.

3895R

3900R

בפרק ט״ו מאמר ג׳ בשבאים הכתפים לשאת אותו ובפרט אם הוא ת״ח [vi] יאמרו׃ [vii]

In Chapter 15 of Discourse 3, when the pallbearers come to carry[2] the deceased, especially if he is a Torah scholar, they should recite:

וּבִנְסֹעַ הַמִּשְׁכָּן יוֹרִידוּ אֹתוֹ הַלְוִיִּם וּבְחָנֹת הַמִּשְׁכָּן יָקִימוּ אֹתוֹ הַלְוִיִּם וְהַזָּר הַקָּרֵב יוּמָת׃ [viii] וַיְהִי בִּנְסֹעַ

When the Tabernacle is to be transported, the Levites shall take it down,[3] and when the Tabernacle is to be set up, the Levites shall erect it; any outsider

3905R

[1] This compilation of biblical verses creates a spiritual progression: first addressing obstacles to the soul's journey (the mountain becoming a plain), then invoking divine power, and finally affirming God's glory filling all creation—a recurring pattern in Ma'avar Yabok's prayers for the deceased.

[2] The original term 'כתפים' literally means 'shoulders,' but in this funeral context refers specifically to the pallbearers who carry the deceased on their shoulders.

[3] The Hebrew uses a concise construction 'בִּנְסֹעַ' (literally 'in the journeying of') which I've expanded slightly for clarity in English.

[i] The phrase "tzorchei talmid chacham" refers to the ritual preparation of a deceased Torah scholar's body for burial, including washing, purification, and dressing in shrouds. The text suggests these rituals should ideally be performed in the scholar's place of study.

[ii] This phrase directs the reader to consult the full explanation elsewhere in the text. Such cross-references are common throughout Ma'avar Yabok, as the work is organized as a reference manual.

[iii] The term "sod" (secret) indicates that the author will provide a mystical/kabbalistic explanation of the practice of accompanying the deceased to burial, beyond its practical or legal dimensions.

[iv] Cf. Chapter 20 of the Second Discourse — The reference indicates that these prohibitions have both practical and mystical reasons that are elaborated in detail elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Chapter 26 of the Second Discourse — The author refers readers to this section for a deeper understanding of the spiritual dimensions of the funeral procession beyond its practical requirements.

[v] The text gives special treatment to a deceased Torah scholar (talmid chacham), reflecting the Jewish tradition of showing particular honor to learned individuals even after death.

[vi] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 15, Discourse 3 — This reference directs the reader to an earlier section of Ma'avar Yabok that contains complete instructions for the ritual of carrying the deceased to burial. The current text is providing specific prayers to be recited at that moment.

[vii] This verse from Numbers establishes a parallel between the sacred transport of the Tabernacle in ancient Israel and the transport of the deceased. Just as only Levites could handle the Tabernacle, the text suggests that only designated individuals (the burial society) should handle the deceased's body, maintaining its sacred dignity.

[vi] Cf. Book of Zechariah — This verse from Zechariah is quoted here as part of a prayer for divine assistance during the transition of death. In its original context, the verse refers to obstacles being removed for Zerubbabel in rebuilding the Temple, but in Ma'avar Yabok, it symbolizes the hope that obstacles to the soul's peaceful journey will be removed. | Cf. Book of Numbers — These verses from Numbers ("Let the power of the Lord be great" and "all the earth shall be filled with the glory of the LORD") were originally spoken by Moses when pleading for divine forgiveness after Israel's lack of faith. In this deathbed context, they serve as a plea for divine mercy and the manifestation of God's greatness in facilitating the soul's transition.

וְהָאָרֹן וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה קוּמָה יְיָ וְיָפֻצוּ
אֹיְבֶיךָ וְיָנֻסוּ מְשַׂנְאֶיךָ מִפָּנֶיךָ: [i] כִּי
מַלְאָכָיו יְצַוֶּה לָךְ לִשְׁמָרְךָ בְּכָל
דְּרָכֶיךָ: עַל כַּפַּיִם יִשָּׂאוּנְךָ פֶּן תִּגֹּף

3665 בָּאֶבֶן רַגְלֶךָ: לֹא תְאֻנֶּה אֵלֶיךָ רָעָה
וְנֶגַע לֹא יִקְרַב בְּאָהֳלֶךָ: [ii] יְיָ אִישׁ
מִלְחָמָה יְיָ שְׁמוֹ: יְיָ יִלָּחֶם לָכֶם
[iv iii] וְאַתֶּם תַּחֲרִישׁוּן:

who approaches shall be put to death.[1] When the Ark set out, Moses would say: 'Arise, O LORD, and let Your enemies be scattered, and let those who 3910R
hate You flee before You.'[2] For He will command
His angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways. They will bear you up in their hands,[3] lest you strike your foot against a stone. No evil shall befall you, nor shall any plague come near your 3915R
dwelling. The LORD is a man of war;[4] the LORD is His name. The LORD will fight for you, and you shall be silent.[5]

עיין בזהר פרשת בשלח [v] סגולת

3670 וכח הב׳ פסוקים אלו ועוד טובא

Having examined the Zohar portion of Beshalach, the two verses cited here possess special protective 3920R

[1] The Hebrew term 'הַזָּר' (ha-zar) specifically means 'the stranger' or 'non-Levite' in this context, referring to anyone not authorized to handle sacred objects.
[2] In the context of funeral practices, this verse serves as a spiritual protection, asking that any negative forces be dispersed as the deceased is transported to burial.
[3] This passage from Psalm 91 takes on special significance in Ma'avar Yabok, as it provides a vivid image of angels carrying the soul safely on its journey after death.
[4] This anthropomorphic description of God as a warrior appears in the Song at the Sea (Exodus 15:3). In the funeral context, it emphasizes God's power to overcome the obstacles of death and guide the soul to its resting place.
[5] The Hebrew 'תַּחֲרִישׁוּן' has connotations beyond mere silence, suggesting respectful stillness and trust in divine action. In the funeral context, it instructs mourners to maintain reverent silence during the transport of the deceased.

[i] This verse was traditionally recited when the Ark was transported in ancient Israel. In the context of a funeral, it serves to disperse negative spiritual forces that might impede the soul's journey, with the deceased's body metaphorically compared to the sacred Ark.
[ii] These verses from Psalm 91, known as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons), are believed to have special protective properties against harmful spiritual forces. Their inclusion in the funeral ritual creates spiritual protection for both the deceased and those carrying the body.
[iii] This final verse instructs mourners to maintain respectful silence while God fights spiritual battles on behalf of the deceased. It reflects the Jewish belief that at sacred moments of transition, human silence allows divine action to manifest more fully.
[iv] Cf. Numbers 1:51 — This first verse is quoted directly from Numbers 1:51, establishing the sacred status of the Tabernacle and the exclusive right of the Levites to handle it. | Cf. Numbers 10:35 — This verse from Numbers 10:35 was recited by Moses whenever the Ark set out during Israel's wilderness journeys. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a protective prayer when moving the deceased, with the Ark representing the soul's journey. | Cf. Psalm 91:11-12 — These verses from the 'Song of Afflictions' (Psalm 91) are included specifically for their protective qualities, invoking angelic guardianship for the deceased's soul during its transition. | Cf. Exodus 15:3 — This declaration of God as a warrior comes from the Song at the Sea (Exodus 15). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it invokes divine power to overcome the obstacles that might impede the soul's journey. | Cf. Exodus 14:14 — This final verse from Exodus 14:14 completes the protective formula, assuring that God will fight on behalf of the deceased's soul while humans maintain reverential silence during this sacred transition.
[v] The author directs readers to a specific section of the Zohar (the primary text of Jewish mysticism) related to the Torah portion of Beshalach (Exodus 13:17-17:16). This reference serves to establish authoritative support for the ritual practices being described.

אמרי בהו יושבי על מדין:[i][ii]

powers,[A] and those who dwell in contemplation of judgment say many additional things about them.[B]

יכוונו הנושאים את המטה כשמתחלפים מזה לזה להבריח מעליו רוחות הנקרא פורחות[iii] ויכוונו לפחות לעמוד קודם שישימו אותו בקברו ז׳ פעמים:[iv] ומה טוב שכל המתחלפים תחת הארגז יאמר כל אחד מהם פסוקים הנזכרים למעלה ויוסיף פסוק זה:[v]

Those carrying the bier,[1] when they exchange with one another, should have the intention of driving away from him the spirits called "flyers,"[2] and they should at least intend to stop [and rest the coffin] seven times[3] before they place him in his grave. And how good it is that all those who take turns carrying the coffin should each recite the verses mentioned above and add this verse:

[A] Or: "the special virtue and power of these two verses" — The Hebrew word 'segulah' specifically refers to a spiritual remedy or protective measure with mystical properties, while 'koach' refers to power or efficacy. This alternate translation more precisely captures the technical mystical meaning of these terms in the context of Kabbalistic literature.

[B] Or: "and the sages who sit in judgment say much more about them" — The phrase 'yoshvei al madin' could refer specifically to rabbinic authorities who make legal judgments, rather than to those engaged in spiritual contemplation of divine judgment. The context suggests these are authoritative interpretations from scholarly sources.

[1] The Hebrew 'המטה' literally means 'the bed' but in this context refers specifically to the funeral bier or coffin. This terminology reflects the Jewish conception of death as sleep, with burial as placing the deceased to rest.

[2] I've translated 'רוחות הנקרא פורחות' as 'spirits called "flyers"' to maintain the technical term while making the meaning clear. In kabbalistic literature, these are a specific class of harmful spiritual entities that are attracted to the deceased during transport.

[3] I've added '[and rest the coffin]' for clarity, as the Hebrew 'לעמוד' (to stand) in this context specifically means to stop and set down the coffin temporarily before continuing the procession.

[i] This phrase literally means 'those who sit in judgment' and refers to rabbinic authorities or sages who render halakhic (Jewish legal) decisions. In Kabbalistic contexts, it often refers to those who have mastered both legal and mystical dimensions of Torah.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Beshalach — The Zohar in Beshalach discusses how certain biblical verses create spiritual protection when recited. The verses referred to here are likely 'The LORD shall fight for you, and you shall hold your peace' (Exodus 14:14) and 'The LORD is a man of war, the LORD is His name' (Exodus 15:3), which appear in the surrounding context of the passage being translated. These verses are considered particularly powerful for spiritual protection when carrying the deceased. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 15 — The reference connects to the broader discussion in Ma'avar Yabok about proper funeral rituals, specifically how certain biblical verses create spiritual protection during the transport of the deceased. The Zohar reference is meant to provide authoritative support for the ritual practice being described.

[iii] The term 'porchot' (flyers) refers to a specific category of harmful spirits in Jewish mystical tradition that are believed to hover around the deceased during transport to burial. According to kabbalistic belief, these entities are drawn to the body during this liminal period and must be actively repelled through proper intention (kavvanah) and recitation of protective verses.

[iv] The number seven has profound significance in Jewish ritual practice, particularly relating to transitions. The seven stops mirror the seven heavens through which the soul must ascend, creating a corresponding earthly ritual to facilitate this spiritual journey. This practice also recalls the seven hakafot (circuits) performed around the deceased before leaving the house, forming a complete ritual framework for the journey from home to grave.

[v] Cf. Zohar — The reference to spirits called "flyers" (porchot) derives from Zoharic conceptions of harmful spiritual entities that can attach themselves to the deceased during transport to burial. The practice described here is intended as spiritual protection for the soul during this vulnerable transition. | Cf. Talmud — The practice of resting the coffin seven times before burial likely derives from the Talmudic teaching about seven stations when leaving a cemetery, here inverted

שְׂרָפִים עֹמְדִים מִמַּעַל לוֹ[i] שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם שֵׁשׁ כְּנָפַיִם לְאֶחָד[ii] בִּשְׁתַּיִם יְכַסֶּה פָּנָיו[iii] וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְכַסֶּה רַגְלָיו[iv] וּבִשְׁתַּיִם יְעוֹפֵף:[v][vi]

Seraphim stood above Him,[1] each one having six wings:[2] with two he covered his face, and with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew.[3]

3685 והוא מסוגל[vii] לאדם גדול:[viii]

This is especially suitable for a distinguished person.

נייחא גדולה לנפש הנפטר בשבע הקפות[ix] וכוונתם מתבאר בפרק י״ז מאמר ג׳ ועוד בפרק ל׳ מאמר ה׳: וזהו סדר כפי הנמצא

There is great solace for the soul of the departed through the seven circuits (hakafot),[4] the significance of which is explained in Chapter 17 of Discourse 3 and further in Chapter 30 of Discourse 3935R

[1]The Hebrew 'lo' (לו) meaning 'to him' or 'above him' refers to God in Isaiah's vision. In funeral contexts, this verse creates a parallel between God's throne surrounded by angels and the deceased being surrounded by divine protection.

[2]The number six in Jewish mysticism often represents completeness within the created world (created in six days). In Ma'avar Yabok, the six-winged angels symbolize the complete protection offered to the soul during its transition.

[3]The Hebrew term 'ye'ofef' (יְעוֹפֵף) implies continuous flying or hovering. This connects to the concept of the soul's journey after death, with angels constantly accompanying it between worlds.

[4]The Hebrew term 'hakafot' refers to ritual circumambulations or circuits, usually made in a counterclockwise direction. In this funeral context, they involve carrying or walking around the deceased's body or bier, usually while reciting psalms or prayers. The number seven connects to various Jewish symbolism including the seven days of creation and seven divine attributes.

and applied to the approach to burial. This reversal creates symmetry in the journey to and from the grave.

[i]This refers to Isaiah's vision (Isaiah 6:2) of angelic beings standing above God's throne. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is recited during funeral processions to create a spiritual connection between earthly burial rituals and heavenly realities.

[ii]The repetition of "six wings" emphasizes the complete nature of the angelic beings. In kabbalistic interpretation, these six wings correspond to the six sefirot from Chesed to Yesod, representing different divine attributes that protect the soul during its journey after death.

[iii]The covering of the face symbolizes the angels' reverence before divine glory. In death rituals, this represents how even celestial beings cannot directly gaze upon divine mysteries, teaching humility to mourners.

[iv]The covering of the feet is interpreted in Jewish mystical tradition as concealing the angels' lower nature. In funeral contexts, this represents how the soul's earthly attachments are covered as it transitions to spiritual realms.

[v]The flight of the Seraphim represents spiritual movement and service. In Ma'avar Yabok, this image inspires the visualization of angels escorting the departed soul as it 'flies' to its heavenly destination.

[vi]Cf. Isaiah 6:2 — This verse is quoted during funeral processions in Ma'avar Yabok to invoke divine protection through angelic imagery. In the context of death rituals, it connects the earthly funeral procession with celestial realities, suggesting that just as the Seraphim attend the divine throne, angels attend the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Zohar — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is likely intended to help those attending the funeral visualize the soul being escorted by angelic beings on its journey. The six wings correspond to different divine attributes and protective powers that shield the soul during its transition.

[vii]This refers to the preceding verse (Seraphim standing above...) having special spiritual efficacy or power when recited.

[viii]In this context, 'adam gadol' (distinguished person) specifically means a Torah scholar or spiritually significant individual, for whom these special prayers and practices are considered particularly appropriate.

[ix]The concept that seven circuits (hakafot) around the deceased's body provide 'great comfort' (niycha gedolah) to the departed soul is a kabbalistic idea not found in earlier rabbinic sources. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's integration of mystical practices into funeral rituals.

3690 בדברי חכמים ברחיצה הגדולה המיוחסת להלל הזקן:[i][ii]

5. This is the order according to what is found in the words of the Sages regarding the great washing ritual attributed to Hillel the Elder:[1] 3940R

בכל הקפה יאמר יושב בסתר עליון עד כי אתה ה׳ מחסי סימן צ״א ויתן בכל פעם לפחות
3695 פרוטה לצדקה על המת או יפרישנו בכיסו לכפרת נפשו:[iii]

In each circuit, he shall recite [the psalm beginning with] "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High" until "For You, O LORD, are my refuge"[A] (Psalm 91) and each time shall give at least one perutah (small coin) to charity on behalf of the deceased, or set it aside in his pocket for the atonement of his soul.[2] 3945R

ויאמר: הֲרֵינִי נוֹתֵן פְּרוּטָה זוּ לִצְדָקָה[iv] עַל כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל וְעַל

I hereby give this coin for charity[B] on behalf of all Israel[3] and for (so-and-so), this departed one, for the 3950R

[A] Or: "During each circuit, he should recite from "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High" through "For You, LORD, are my refuge"" — This alternate translation makes it clearer that a specific portion of Psalm 91 is being recited, not the entire psalm. It also uses a more contemporary phrasing that might be more accessible to modern readers.

[B] Or: "I am giving this coin as tzedakah" — This alternate translation preserves the Hebrew term 'tzedakah' which carries nuances beyond the English 'charity,' including connotations of justice and righteousness. This might be preferable in contexts where the audience is familiar with Jewish terminology.

[1] This 'great washing' (rechitzah ha-gedolah) refers to the ritual purification of the deceased (tahara). By attributing it to Hillel the Elder, a renowned sage from the first century BCE, the text seeks to establish historical legitimacy for practices that were largely developed in medieval kabbalistic circles.

[2] The Hebrew 'kaparat nafsho' reflects the theological concept that charitable giving can serve as atonement (kapparah) for the deceased, helping to cleanse the soul of any remaining spiritual blemishes as it transitions to the afterlife.

[3] Including 'all Israel' in charitable dedications is a common practice that reflects the concept of Jewish collective responsibility and mutual spiritual benefit.

[i] The attribution of the 'great washing ritual' to Hillel the Elder (c. 110 BCE-10 CE) is significant. While Hillel was known for various teachings, this specific attribution of funeral purification practices to him is unique to Ma'avar Yabok and related kabbalistic works, representing an attempt to provide ancient authority to mystical practices.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The text references two specific chapters within Ma'avar Yabok itself that explain the mystical significance of the seven circuits (hakafot) made around the deceased's body. This self-referential citation indicates that the hakafot ritual has been treated in depth elsewhere in the book, showing the interconnected nature of Ma'avar Yabok's structure. | Cf. Hillel the Elder — The text attributes a specific purification ritual (referred to as 'the great washing') to Hillel the Elder, a renowned sage from the late Second Temple period. This attribution connects the funeral practices detailed in Ma'avar Yabok to ancient rabbinic authority, legitimizing them through association with this revered historical figure.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 91 — Psalm 91 ("He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High") is considered in Jewish tradition to have protective powers against harmful spiritual forces, making it particularly appropriate for funeral rituals where the soul is considered vulnerable during its transition to the afterlife. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 17 — In this earlier section, the author explains the spiritual significance of the seven circuits (hakafot) around the deceased's body and how they comfort the departing soul. This present instruction builds on that explanation by providing the specific ritual details.

[iv] This formula is recited when giving charity (tzedakah) on behalf of the deceased, reflecting the Jewish belief that charitable acts benefit the souls of the departed. A 'perutah' is a small coin, representing the minimum denomination that fulfills the obligation of charity.

(פלוני) זֶה הַנִּפְטָר[i] לְמָנוּחַת
נִשְׁמָתוֹ בְּגַן עֵדֶן:[ii iii]

repose of his soul in the Garden of Eden.[1]

בכל הקפה אחת[iv] שיצא
החזן[v] מן השורה יאמר אנא בכח
וגו'[vi] ומצאתי כי טוב לומר
י"ג מדות.[vii] וכשהחזן אומר
ויעבור[viii] שאז הוא התעוררות
הרחמים[ix] יאמרו כל העם:[x]

In each circuit (hakafah)[2] when the prayer leader steps out from the row, he should recite "Ana Bekoach"[3] etc. I have found it beneficial to also recite the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy.[4] When the prayer leader recites "Vaya'avor" (And He passed), which is when divine mercy is awakened,[5] all the people should respond:

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ

May it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our

[1]The translation preserves the theological concept that charitable acts can provide spiritual benefit and rest for the deceased's soul in the afterlife, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok.
[2]The term 'hakafah' specifically refers to the ritual circling of the deceased's bier before burial, which is performed seven times according to kabbalistic tradition. These circuits are believed to comfort the soul and provide spiritual protection.
[3]I've kept this prayer name untranslated as it is commonly known by its Hebrew title. The prayer begins with the words 'Ana bekoach gedulat yemincha' (Please, with the strength of Your great right hand).
[4]This refers to the enumeration of God's compassionate qualities listed in Exodus 34:6-7, beginning with 'Adonai, Adonai, El rachum v'chanun' (LORD, LORD, God merciful and gracious).
[5]This reflects the kabbalistic concept that certain prayers at specific moments create openings between the human and divine realms, allowing for greater flow of divine compassion.

[i]The word 'ploni' (פלוני) is a placeholder where the name of the deceased would be inserted. The text instructs the reader to substitute the actual name here.
[ii]This phrase reflects the Jewish belief in Gan Eden (Garden of Eden) as the place where righteous souls find rest after death. The charitable act is understood to facilitate this spiritual rest.
[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21, Second Discourse — This chapter explains that charity (tzedakah) given for the deceased provides atonement for their soul. The text specifically states that giving at least six perutot (small coins) serves as 'ransom for the soul' of the departed, emphasizing the spiritual efficacy of charitable giving in facilitating the soul's journey after death.
[iv]This refers to one of the seven ritual circuits (hakafot) performed around the deceased's bier during funeral rituals, based on the practice described in Ma'avar Yabok.
[v]The prayer leader who guides the funeral proceedings.
[vi]This is an abbreviation for 'Ana Bekoach,' a kabbalistic prayer attributed to the 1st-century sage Rabbi Nehunya ben HaKanah. It contains 42 words that correspond to the 42-letter divine name, and is believed to have special protective powers during spiritual transitions like death.
[vii]This refers to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7) which are recited as part of penitential prayers, especially when seeking divine forgiveness and compassion.
[viii]This is the opening word of the biblical passage containing the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6). The complete phrase is 'Vaya'avor Adonai al panav vayikra' (And the LORD passed before him and proclaimed).
[ix]This phrase refers to the kabbalistic concept that the recitation of certain prayers at specific moments can 'awaken' or activate divine mercy in the upper worlds.
[x]Cf. Ana Bekoach — Ana Bekoach is a kabbalistic prayer often recited during funeral rituals to provide spiritual protection for the deceased's soul during its transition to the afterlife. | Cf. Thirteen Attributes of Mercy — The Thirteen Attributes (Yud-Gimel Midot) are recited as a powerful supplication for divine mercy and forgiveness. In this funeral context, they're used to request compassion for the deceased during their soul's transition. | Cf. Vaya'avor — The word 'Vaya'avor' (And He passed) begins the recitation of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy. Kabbalistic tradition holds that this specific moment during prayer creates a special opportunity for divine mercy to be awakened.

וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתְּרַחֵם עַל (פלוני) זֶה הַנִּפְטָר וְתִמְחוֹל לוֹ כָּל פְּשָׁעָיו וַעֲוֹנוֹתָיו[i] יְיָ יְיָ אֵל רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן[ii]: 3710

fathers,[A] that You have mercy upon (name), this departed one,[B] and forgive him all his transgressions and iniquities.[1] LORD, LORD, God, merciful and gracious.[2] 3960R

ויתנו הפרוטות לעניים אז או אם אינם מצויים שם יחזר אחריהם תוך כ״ד שעות. ובא״י היו נוהגים לחתוך א׳ מטבע זהב כגון א׳ ציקי״נו[iv] לחתיכות דקות להשים אותו עליו עם כסף ונחשת וזה לאדם גדול[v]: 3715

They should give the coins to the poor at that time, or if they are not present there, one should search for them within twenty-four hours. In the Land of Israel, they used to cut a gold coin, such as a zecchino, into thin pieces to place upon him along with silver and copper [coins], and this [was done] for a distinguished person. 3965R 3970R

[A] Or: "May it be favorable before You, LORD our God and God of our ancestors" — This translation better captures the formal, deferential tone of addressing the divine in traditional Jewish prayers, where God is approached indirectly through the formulaic "milfanecha" (from before You). This would be preferable in a more literal or traditional rendering.

[B] Or: "(name), this deceased person" — While "departed one" has a gentle, euphemistic quality appropriate for liturgical language, "deceased person" might be preferred in contexts requiring more direct language, particularly in academic or descriptive treatments of the ritual.

[1] The prayer follows the theological framework of Ma'avar Yabok that emphasizes the power of confession and atonement even after death, reflecting the book's view that proper spiritual care can continue to benefit the soul in its posthumous journey.

[2] In the Jewish tradition, this prayer is typically recited during funeral rituals or when visiting graves, especially during the first thirty days after death. It reflects the belief that prayers of the living can benefit the deceased by securing divine mercy for their souls.

[i] The text uses two terms for sins: "pesha'av" (transgressions, referring to rebellious sins) and "avonotav" (iniquities, referring to intentional sins). This reflects the comprehensive nature of the prayer seeking complete forgiveness for all categories of sins.

[ii] This is the beginning of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7), a liturgical formula frequently recited in prayers for forgiveness. The full formula would continue with "אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב־חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת" (slow to anger, abounding in kindness and truth), but only the opening is quoted here.

[iii] Cf. Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (Exodus 34:6-7) — This prayer borrows directly from the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, a central text for seeking divine forgiveness. This reference would have signaled to readers that the prayer follows in the tradition of seeking atonement through appeal to God's merciful qualities rather than through human merit. | Cf. Tziduk HaDin prayers — This prayer appears within the larger context of Tziduk HaDin (Justification of the Divine Judgment) prayers recited at funerals, which acknowledge God's righteousness even in the face of death while seeking mercy for the deceased.

[iv] A zecchino was a Venetian gold coin widely used throughout the Mediterranean region during the medieval and early modern periods. Its mention here shows the Italian influence on the author's context.

[v] The term 'adam gadol' (distinguished person) typically refers to a Torah scholar or community leader of high standing, indicating that more elaborate charitable practices were reserved for those of higher social or religious status.

[vi] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage provides specific instructions about the charitable donations made during funeral rituals. The reference to customs in the Land of Israel suggests the author was documenting differing practices between diaspora communities and those in Israel. | Cf. Chevra Kadisha practices — The text references the traditional Jewish burial society practice of giving charity on behalf of the deceased as part of the funeral rites. The specification of twenty-four hours indicates the urgency of fulfilling this obligation. | Cf. Zohar on charity for the dead — The practice of placing coins on the deceased likely derives from the kabbalistic notion that charity has special power to elevate the soul after death, as discussed in the Zohar. The specific mention of gold, silver, and copper may reflect the kabbalistic correspondence between different metals and different sefirot or divine attributes.

אלו הם ההקפות על סדר שם של
3720 מ״ב:[i][ii]

These are the circuits (hakafot) according to the order of the 42-letter Name:[1]

אֵל בָּרוּךְ גָּדוֹל יֵרָאֶה תֹּם
צִדְקוֹתָיו.[iii] וְיִפְתַּח לוֹ מָקוֹם
קִבְרֵי אֲבוֹתָיו. וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה
לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו:[iv]

God, blessed and great, shall see the completeness of his righteousness, and shall open for him the place of his ancestors' graves, and shall send atonement for 3975R
his guilt,[2] and shall extend His compassion to him.[3]

3725 קָדוֹשׁ רַחוּם עֶלְיוֹן[v] שׁוּר טוֹהַר
נַפְשׁוֹ. וְחַלְצֵהוּ פֶּן תֵּאָכְלֵהוּ
לַהַט הֶחָרֶב בְּאֵשׁוֹ.[vi] וְיִכָּנֵס לְגַן

Holy, Merciful, Most High,[4] behold the purity of his soul. And deliver him lest he be consumed by the flaming fire of the sword.[5] May he enter Your Gar-

[1]The original Hebrew term 'hakafot' refers to ritual circuits or processions, similar to those performed during Simchat Torah or around a wedding couple. In this funeral context, these circuits are performed around the deceased's bier. The '42-letter Name' (Shem Mem-Bet) is a mystical divine name in Kabbalah, typically encoded in the initial letters of the prayer 'Ana Bekoach.' The structure of this ritual, with seven circuits, corresponds to the seven lines of six letters each that comprise this name.

[2]The term 'כַּפָּרָה' (kapparah) carries deeper significance in Jewish thought than simple forgiveness—it represents a complete spiritual cleansing and atonement. In the context of funeral prayers, it refers to the purification of the soul as it transitions to the afterlife.

[3]This prayer appears as part of the hakafot (circuit) ritual where mourners walk around the deceased's bier seven times before burial. Each circuit includes prayers that follow mystical patterns, with this one specifically structured around the first three letters of the Hebrew alphabet.

[4]These divine epithets are arranged in a specific order that progresses from aspects of divine judgment ('Holy') to divine compassion ('Merciful') to divine transcendence ('Most High'), creating a pathway for the soul's ascent through various spiritual realms.

[5]The Hebrew phrase has a double meaning, referring both to the biblical flaming sword guarding Eden and to the spiritual fires of judgment that might impede the soul's journey after death.

[i]This phrase refers to ritual circuits (hakafot) structured according to the mystical 42-letter Name of God (Shem Mem-Bet). In kabbalistic tradition, this name was often divided into seven groups of six letters each, which explains the seven circuits mentioned in the following text. This name was considered especially powerful for protection and spiritual elevation.

[ii]Cf. 42-letter Name of God (Shem Mem-Bet) — This refers to a mystical 42-letter divine name in Kabbalah, commonly used in protective prayers. In Ma'avar Yabok, it appears specifically in deathbed and burial rituals. The seven circuits (hakafot) mentioned here correspond to the seven groups of six letters that make up this 42-letter name. | Cf. Prayer 'Ana Bekoach' — The 42-letter Name is encoded in the first letters of the words in the prayer 'Ana Bekoach,' which appears earlier in Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed ritual. These circuits (hakafot) are structured around this same mystical name. | Cf. Hakafot rituals — The ritual of seven circuits (hakafot) around the bier has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok for comforting the deceased's soul. Each circuit includes recitation of Psalm 91 and charitable giving for the deceased's atonement.

[iii]This prayer uses a literary device where the first three words begin with the Hebrew letters א-ב-ג, forming the beginning of an alphabetical acrostic corresponding to the 42-letter divine name (Shem Mem-Bet).

[iv]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This prayer appears to be part of the hakafot (circuit) prayers performed around the bier during funeral rituals in Ma'avar Yabok. The text follows the pattern of the 42-letter divine name (Shem Mem-Bet) prayers, with triplets of words arranged in acrostic form. This specific section uses the first three letters of the Hebrew alphabet (אבג) to begin each phrase.

[v]This threefold designation of God ('Holy, Merciful, Most High') creates a parallel with the three holy angels mentioned in the first circuit prayer and reflects the Kabbalistic structure of the prayer sequence that progresses through the divine attributes.

[vi]This phrase alludes to the flaming sword that guarded Eden after Adam and Eve's expulsion (Genesis 3:24). In Kabbalistic thought, this represents the negative spiritual forces that might impede the soul's journey after death.

עֲדָנָיו וְלֹא יִזָּכְרוּ עוֹד עֲוֹנָיו. וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו:[i][ii] 3730

den of Eden,[1] and may his sins be remembered no more. And may You send atonement for his guilt and extend Your compassion to him. 3980R

נָא גָּדוֹל דָּגוּל[iii] יְגַדֵּל כֹּחַ שְׁמִירָתוֹ. וְיִזְכֶּה לִכָּנֵס לְנוֹגַהּ וְעָנָן מְסָכָּתוֹ.[iv] וּבוֹ יַעֲלֶה וְלֹא יֵרֵד.[v] וְלֹא יִזָּכֵר לוֹ עָוֹן וָמֶרֶד. וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו:[vi] 3735

Please, Great and Distinguished One,[2] magnify the power of his protection. May he merit to enter the brightness and cloud of Your canopy.[3] Through it may he ascend and not descend,[4] and may his iniquity and rebellion not be remembered. Send atonement for his guilt and grant him Your compassion. 3985R

בְּרַחֲמֵי טָהוֹר רַחֲמֵהוּ.[vii] צְדָקָה

With the compassion of the Pure One,[5] have mercy

[1]The possessive form 'Your Garden of Eden' (rather than simply 'Garden of Eden') emphasizes the personal relationship between God and the afterlife realm, reflecting the Kabbalistic concept that divine presence permeates and sustains the heavenly paradise.

[2]The opening phrase 'נָא גָּדוֹל דָּגוּל' continues an acrostic pattern based on the 42-letter Divine Name, with both divine epithets beginning with the same Hebrew letter (gimmel).

[3]This imagery evokes the divine protection described in biblical texts, where God's presence is manifested as both brightness (representing revelation and glory) and cloud (representing mystery and shelter).

[4]According to kabbalistic understanding in Ma'avar Yabok, the soul's proper journey after death is upward through spiritual realms. This prayer seeks to ensure the deceased's soul continues its ascent without being pulled downward by negative forces or past transgressions.

[5]The Hebrew term 'טָהוֹר' (Pure One) is a divine epithet that appears elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok. This prayer employs multiple divine appellations, each emphasizing different aspects of God's nature.

[i]This prayer closes with a parallel structure to the first hakafah prayer, creating a unified form for all seven hakafot prayers. Each hakafah concludes with this same request for divine compassion.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This prayer is part of the seven hakafot (circuits) performed around the deceased's bier before burial. Each circuit includes recitation of Psalm 91, giving charity for the deceased's soul, and reciting a prayer structured around the 42-letter Divine Name. This text is the second of these seven prayer formulas, corresponding to the second circuit. | Cf. Genesis 3:24 — The phrase 'flaming fire of the sword' (לַהַט הַחֶרֶב בְּאֹשׁוֹ) alludes to the 'flaming sword' (לַהַט הַחֶרֶב) that guarded the way to the Garden of Eden after Adam and Eve's expulsion. The prayer asks for the deceased to be allowed entry into Eden, past this fiery barrier.

[iii]This opening address to God uses two adjectives that both begin with the Hebrew letter gimmel, continuing the acrostic pattern of the prayer sequence that corresponds to the 42-letter Divine Name.

[iv]The imagery of 'brightness and cloud of Your canopy' draws on biblical descriptions of divine protection and presence, particularly from Exodus where God appeared in a cloud, and from Psalm 91 which speaks of divine shelter.

[v]This phrase reflects the kabbalistic understanding of death as an ascent through spiritual realms. The emphasis on ascending without descending expresses the hope that the soul will not be pulled downward by negative spiritual forces.

[vi]Cf. Psalm 91 — This prayer echoes the protective imagery of Psalm 91, where God provides shelter and refuge to those who trust in Him. It adapts these themes to the context of a soul's journey after death. | Cf. Shem Mem-Bet — This prayer is the third in a sequence of seven prayers that correspond to the 42-letter Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet). Each prayer follows a similar structure and is recited during one of the seven circuits (hakafot) performed around the deceased's bier before burial. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 15, Third Discourse — The phrase 'may he ascend and not descend' alludes to the kabbalistic teaching that the soul should only ascend through spiritual realms after death, and not be pulled downward by negative forces. This is a central concept in Ma'avar Yabok's mystical understanding of death.

[vii]This opening phrase invokes divine compassion using the divine attribute 'Pure One' (טָהוֹר). The repetition of the root רחם (mercy/compassion) creates emphasis through wordplay.

תָּמִיד גְּמָלֵהוּ. וּמִנַּחַל עֲדָנֶיךָ
תַּשְׁקֵהוּ. וְיִפָּתְחוּ לוֹ שַׁעֲרֵי
3740 יְרוּשָׁלַיִם. וּמִיכָאֵל יַקְרִיבֵהוּ
לִפְנֵי שׁוֹכֵן שָׁמַיִם.[i] וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה
לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ[ii] וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו: [iii]

upon him. Always grant him righteousness.[1] From the river of Your delights, give him drink. May the gates of Jerusalem be opened for him. And may Michael bring him near before the Dweller of Heaven.[2] May He send atonement for his guilt and bestow His mercies upon him. 3990R 3995R

חַי קָדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ[iv] טָהֳרַ
נַפְשׁוֹ עֶלְיוֹן. וּבֵית מִקְדָּשׁ
3745 וְאַפִּרְיוֹן[v] יִפָּתְחוּ לוֹ בְּרָצוֹן.
וּמִיכָאֵל יַכְנִיסֵהוּ בְּשָׂשׂוֹן.[vi]
וּבְשָׂשׂוֹן. וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ
וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו: [vii]

May the Living, Holy, Blessed One purify his soul on high.[A] And may the Temple and the royal pavilion open to him with favor.[B] And may Michael usher him in with joy, with happiness and gladness.[3] And may He send atonement for his guilt and extend His mercy to him. 4000R

[A] Or: "May the Living, Holy, Blessed One purify his exalted soul" — The Hebrew 'עֶלְיוֹן' could modify either the divine subject ('the Most High') or the object ('his exalted soul'). This alternative reading takes it as describing the quality of the soul rather than the location of purification.

[B] Or: "And may the gates of the Sanctuary and the divine chamber be opened willingly for him" — This alternative translation emphasizes the metaphorical nature of these heavenly spaces and the concept that they actively welcome the worthy soul rather than merely being accessible to it.

[1] The phrase 'צְדָקָה תָּמִיד גְּמָלֵהוּ' could alternatively be translated as 'Always bestow charity upon him,' as the term צדקה has the dual meaning of righteousness and charitable giving. In this context, it likely refers to divine benevolence toward the deceased.

[2] The phrase 'שׁוֹכֵן שָׁמַיִם' (literally 'Dweller of Heaven') is a circumlocution for God, reflecting the Jewish practice of using indirect references to the divine, particularly in liturgical contexts.

[3] The Hebrew uses two synonyms for joy (simcha and sasson) which appear together in biblical passages describing redemption. This repetition creates emphasis and conveys the complete and perfect nature of the joy experienced in the afterlife.

[i] In Jewish angelology, Michael serves as Israel's guardian and advocate before God. Here, his role is as psychopomp—guiding the soul through the heavenly realms to divine judgment.

[ii] The theme of divine atonement (כפרה) for the deceased's guilt (אשמתו) reflects the Jewish belief that death itself serves as atonement, especially when accompanied by proper rituals.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 36:8-9 — The phrase 'from the river of Your delights' (מִנַּחַל עֲדָנֶיךָ) directly references Psalm 36:8-9, which describes divine abundance. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this refers to the soul's spiritual sustenance in the afterlife. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This prayer is the fourth in a sequence of seven prayers recited during the hakafot (circuits) around the bier before burial. Each prayer follows the same structure, concluding with 'May He send atonement for his guilt and bestow His mercies upon him.' The seven prayers correspond to the seven letters of the 42-letter Divine Name. | Cf. Zohar — The mention of Michael bringing the soul before the 'Dweller of Heaven' reflects the Zoharic concept that Michael serves as the High Priest in the celestial Temple and as the advocate for souls in the heavenly court, particularly for the people of Israel.

[iv] This opening phrase contains three divine epithets: 'Living,' 'Holy,' and 'Blessed,' which together represent aspects of God's nature relevant to the soul's transition after death.

[v] The 'Temple' and 'pavilion' are metaphors for different heavenly reception areas for the soul. The Temple (Beit Mikdash) represents the cosmic counterpart to the earthly Temple, while the appiryon (from Song of Songs 3:9) represents the royal canopy or palanquin prepared for honored souls.

[vi] In Jewish angelology, Michael is often depicted as the angelic usher who escorts righteous souls into paradise. This reflects the tradition that each person has a specific angelic guide for the afterlife journey.

[vii] Cf. Psalm 51:4 — The prayer draws on the biblical concept of divine purification of the soul, similar to David's plea in Psalm 51 | Cf. Song of Songs 3:9 — The text uses this biblical image of the royal pavilion (appiryon) as a metaphor for the celestial reception area for the soul of the

יְהֹוָה גַּלֵּה לַבֵּן פְּדוּתֶךָ זַךְ קָדוֹשׁ.
וְעַל מִזְבַּח הַקֹּדֶשׁ. נִשְׁמָתוֹ תַּחֲזִיק
נְצֶבֶת וּמִפִּי עֶלְיוֹן שָׁם תִּהְיֶה
מְבוֹרֶכֶת. וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ
וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו: [i]

O Lord, reveal Your redemption to the son, pure and holy.[A] And upon the sacred altar, may his soul stand firm,[B] and from the mouth of the Most High may it be blessed there. And may He send atonement for his guilt and extend His mercies to him.[1]

שׁוֹכֵן קֶדֶם וּמֵאָז צֶדֶק יֹשֶׁר תּוּמֶיךָ.
יְהִי לְנֶפֶשׁ זֶה מַחֲזִיק וְתוֹמֵךְ.
וּבַעֲרֻבוֹת לְפָנֶיךָ יְשַׁמֵּשׁ. [ii] וְיוֹמָם
וְלַיְלָה לֹא יָמוּשׁ. [iii] וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה
לְנִשְׁמָתוֹ [iv] וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו: [v]

He who dwells from ancient times,[C] whose righteousness and uprightness are Your perfections,[D] may He be a supporter and upholder for this soul.[2] May it serve before You in the celestial plains,[E] and never depart day or night. May He send atonement

[A] Or: "O Yah, reveal to Your pure and holy son Your redemption." — This alternate reading takes 'זַךְ קָדוֹשׁ' (pure and holy) as modifying 'בֵּן' (son) rather than serving as epithets for God. This interpretation would emphasize the deceased's spiritual purity and sanctity as qualities making them worthy of divine redemption.

[B] Or: "And upon the holy altar, may his soul be presented" — The term 'נְצֶבֶת' can also carry connotations of 'being presented' or 'offered up,' which would strengthen the sacrificial metaphor. This reading would emphasize the soul as an offering being presented to God rather than simply standing in the divine presence.

[C] Or: "Dweller of antiquity and eternity" — This alternate translation emphasizes the eternal nature of God with more poetic language that might better capture the metaphysical sense of the original Hebrew.

[D] Or: "Your righteousness, uprightness, and integrity" — This alternate translation is more direct and treats the three nouns as parallel attributes rather than describing them as 'perfections,' which is implied but not explicit in the original.

[E] Or: "And in Aravot [the highest heaven] may it minister before You" — This alternate translation preserves the specific kabbalistic term 'Aravot,' which refers to the seventh and highest heaven in Jewish mystical cosmology, rather than translating it generically as 'celestial plains.'

[1] The formula 'וְיִשְׁלַח כַּפָּרָה לְאַשְׁמָתוֹ וְיִתֵּן אֵלָיו רַחֲמָיו' appears at the end of each of the seven hakafot prayers in Ma'avar Yabok, serving as a standardized closing petition for divine mercy and forgiveness for the deceased.

[2] The Hebrew uses two complementary terms (מַחֲזִיק וְתוֹמֵךְ) that together convey both active strengthening and supportive upholding, reflecting the comprehensive divine care hoped for the departed soul.

deceased | Cf. Book of Daniel, Chapter 12 — The reference to Michael reflects the Jewish tradition of Michael as the guardian angel of Israel who escorts worthy souls to their heavenly abode | Cf. Isaiah 35:10 — The paired terms 'happiness and gladness' echo Isaiah's description of redemption, suggesting the soul's heavenly reception is like the redemptive return to Zion

[i] Cf. Psalm 111:9 — The opening invocation echoes the psalmist's language about God sending redemption, reframing it as a direct plea in the context of a soul's transition after death | Cf. Exodus 40:29 — The prayer metaphorically presents the deceased's soul as an offering on the divine altar, transforming the physical death into a sacred sacrifice | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Sixth Hakafah Prayer — Each of these seven hakafot prayers follows a similar structure, invoking divine attributes associated with letters of the 42-letter Name while seeking mercy for the departed soul's journey

[ii] The term 'Aravot' (עֲרֻבוֹת) refers specifically to the seventh and highest heaven in Jewish mystical tradition, where God's throne is located. This is not merely a poetic reference to heavenly regions but a precise cosmological location in kabbalistic thought.

[iii] This phrase echoes Joshua 1:8 regarding constant meditation on Torah, but here applies to the soul's continuous service in the divine presence, suggesting an eternal state of devotion unbounded by time.

[iv] The concept of 'sending atonement' (כַּפָּרָה) for the soul reflects the Jewish belief that certain spiritual processes continue after death, and that divine mercy can still affect the soul's status in the afterlife.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is the seventh and final prayer of the hakafot ritual. These prayers

for his soul and extend His mercies to him.

ואחר שהשלים ההקפות יאמר[i][ii] And after completing the circuits (hakafot), he shall say:[1]

3760 וְלִבְנֵי הַפִּילַגְשִׁים[iii] אֲשֶׁר לְאַבְרָהָם נָתַן אַבְרָהָם מַתָּנֹת:[iv][v] And to the sons of the concubines[2] who belonged to Abraham, Abraham gave gifts:[3] 4015R

[1]The hakafot ritual described here is part of the Jewish funeral ceremony. Seven ceremonial circuits are performed around the bier of the deceased before burial, each accompanied by recitation of Psalm 91, an act of charity, and prayers structured around the 42-letter Divine Name. The text that follows this instruction contains biblical verses that are to be recited at the conclusion of these circuits.

[2]The Hebrew term "pilagshim" (פִּילַגְשִׁים) refers to women who had a recognized relationship with Abraham that was secondary to his primary wife. While 'concubines' carries potentially negative connotations in English, in biblical context these were legitimate relationships with legal standing, though of lesser status than a full wife.

[3]In the funeral context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse creates a parallel between Abraham's gifts

follow a kabbalistic pattern structured around the 42-letter Divine Name, where each prayer represents a different spiritual aspect of the deceased's journey. The seventh prayer specifically focuses on the soul's continuous service in the highest heaven (Aravot), suggesting the completion of its transition. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The opening phrase 'שׁוֹכֵן קֶדֶם' (Dweller of antiquity) echoes the opening of Psalm 91, which is specifically recommended in Ma'avar Yabok to be recited during these funeral circuits. This creates a textual link between this prayer and the psalm that precedes it in the ritual. | Cf. Zohar — The reference to the soul serving in 'Aravot' draws on kabbalistic teachings about the afterlife, suggesting the deceased's soul has reached the highest level of spiritual existence. This is particularly significant as the concluding prayer of the seven hakafot, symbolizing the complete elevation of the soul.

[i]This instructional line appears after the description of the seven hakafot (ceremonial circuits) around the deceased's bier. These seven hakafot correspond to the structure of the 42-letter Divine Name and represent the soul's progressive elevation through spiritual realms.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, section on funeral rituals — The 'hakafot' (circuits) referred to here are the seven ceremonial encirclements of the deceased's bier before burial. Each circuit includes the recitation of Psalm 91, charitable giving, and a prayer structured around the 42-letter Divine Name. This ritual is believed to provide protection for the soul during its transition to the afterlife. | Cf. Genesis 25:6 — The verse that follows ('To the sons of the concubines that Abraham had, Abraham gave gifts...') is quoted in this context because it provides a biblical basis for the practice of giving charity as part of funeral rites. Just as Abraham gave gifts to separate his concubines' sons, the charitable gifts during hakafot serve to appease spiritual accusers. | Cf. Psalm 78:38 — The verse 'But He, being compassionate, forgave iniquity and did not destroy; many times He turned away His anger, and did not stir up all His wrath' is recited here as a prayer for divine mercy upon the deceased. This verse is traditionally recited three times as part of the Tachanun (supplication) prayers and is believed to have protective properties against spiritual accusers.

[iii]This is a direct quotation from Genesis 25:6, part of the passage describing Abraham's final arrangements before his death. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse appears at the conclusion of the hakafot ritual performed around the deceased's bier, creating a connection between Abraham's gifts to his concubines' sons (whom he sent away) and the charitable gifts distributed during the funeral ritual.

[iv]The verse is deliberately truncated here, omitting the remainder of the biblical passage which states that Abraham "sent them away from his son Isaac eastward, to the land of the east." In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's funeral ritual, this verse likely symbolizes the spiritual gifts or merits transferred to the deceased through charitable donations made on their behalf.

[v]Cf. Genesis 25:6 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse appears at the conclusion of the hakafot (circuit) ritual around the deceased's bier. The author intentionally uses this verse to create a theological parallel between Abraham's gifts and the charitable donations made during funeral rituals. Just as Abraham provided for his sons before sending them away, the community provides spiritual 'gifts' (charity) to accompany the deceased soul on its journey. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok hakafot ritual — This verse connects to the book's repeated emphasis on charity (tzedakah) as spiritual

וְהוּא רַחוּם[i] יְכַפֵּר עָוֹן וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית[ii] וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ:[iii][iv]

And He, being merciful,[1] atones for sin[2] and does not destroy; He frequently turns away His anger[3] and does not arouse all His wrath.

3765 וטוב לעשות ההקפות אלו[v] בבית הקברות אחר צדוק הדין[vi] או בביתו קודם

It is good to perform these circuits[4] (hakafot) in the cemetery after the Tziduk HaDin prayer,[5] or at the deceased's home[6] before the pallbearers carry him. 4020R

to his sons and the charitable donations (gifts) made during the funeral ritual for the spiritual benefit of the deceased. The charitable donations function as 'gifts' that accompany the soul on its journey, just as Abraham gave gifts to his sons before sending them away.

[1]The Hebrew 'v'hu rachum' establishes God's essential nature as merciful before describing His actions. This emphasizes that mercy is not merely something God does but reflects who God is fundamentally.

[2]The Hebrew 'yekhaper avon' uses terminology associated with ritual atonement and purification, connecting this verse to Temple sacrifice concepts. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this suggests that death itself can serve as atonement when approached with proper spiritual intention.

[3]The Hebrew construction 'v'hirbah l'hashiv apo' literally means 'He has abundantly turned away His anger,' emphasizing not just that God turns away anger occasionally, but does so repeatedly and abundantly. This reinforces the theological premise of God's consistent mercy even in the face of human failings.

[4]I've translated 'hakafot' (הקפות) as 'circuits' while also keeping the Hebrew term in parentheses for clarity. These ritual circumambulations have deep significance in Jewish mystical practice, not just for funerals but also in other contexts such as Simchat Torah and Sukkot.

[5]I've kept the transliteration of 'Tziduk HaDin' rather than translating it fully as 'Justification of the Judgment' because it is a specific ritual prayer with this technical name in Jewish tradition.

[6]The Hebrew literally says 'at his home' (בביתו), which in context clearly refers to the home of the

protection for the deceased. The charitable gifts made during the funeral ritual are understood as accompanying the soul on its journey after death, just as Abraham's gifts accompanied his sons when they departed. The verse appears specifically after the hakafot ritual where donations are made with each circuit around the bier.

[i]This verse begins with 'And He, being merciful,' establishing God's compassionate nature as the foundation for the divine actions that follow. In kabbalistic thought, this refers to God's attribute of mercy (rachamim), which moderates the attribute of judgment (din).

[ii]The Hebrew phrase 'and does not destroy' carries particular significance in the context of death rituals, as it implicitly acknowledges God's power to destroy while emphasizing His restraint, offering comfort to those facing mortality.

[iii]The image of God 'not arousing all His wrath' draws on ancient Near Eastern royal imagery, where a king's full wrath would mean total destruction. The text suggests that even in judgment, God exercises merciful restraint—a crucial theological point when contemplating divine judgment at death.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This verse is quoted directly from Psalm 78:38 and appears frequently in Jewish liturgy, especially in penitential contexts. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a prayer for divine mercy at the moment of death, particularly when recited three times by those attending the dying person. The verse emphasizes God's compassionate nature even in the face of human sin, making it especially appropriate as a plea for mercy during the soul's transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok funeral ritual instructions — The text specifically instructs that this verse should be recited three times by each person throwing earth into the grave. According to Ma'avar Yabok, this practice helps weaken 'the heads of the destroyer' (רָאשֵׁי הַמַּשְׁחִית) and alleviates the suffering of 'chibut ha-kever' (beating in the grave) for the deceased. This contextualizes the verse not merely as a general prayer for mercy but as having specific protective power against negative spiritual forces during burial.

[v]The term 'hakafot' (circuits) refers to a ritual of walking in circles around the bier of the deceased. This practice is based on kabbalistic principles and is believed to have protective properties for the soul's journey after death.

[vi]Tziduk HaDin (Justification of the Judgment) is a prayer recited at funerals that acknowledges the righteousness of divine judgment, even in death. It begins with the verse 'The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are justice' (Deut. 32:4).

שישאוהו הכתפים:[i] [ii]

בפרק כ״א מאמר ב׳ יתבאר סוד צדוק הדין:[iii] והרבה דינים ממנו הם בפרק כ״ו מאמר ה׳:[iv] וסדר צדוק הדין שיאמר האבל[v] הוא:[vi]

In Chapter 21 of Discourse 2,[1] the mystical significance of Tziduk HaDin[2] (Justification of the Divine Judgment) will be explained. Many of its laws are also found in Chapter 26 of Discourse 5. The order of Tziduk HaDin that the mourner should recite[3] is: 4025R

צַדִּיק אַתָּה יְיָ עַל כָּל הַבָּא עָלֵינוּ:[vii] [viii]

Righteous are You, O LORD, concerning all that has come upon us.[4]

deceased, not the home of the person performing the ritual.

[1] I've translated 'מאמר' as 'Discourse' rather than simply 'section' to preserve the specific structural terminology used in Ma'avar Yabok. This book is organized into major discourses (מאמרים) which are further divided into chapters (פרקים).

[2] I've translated 'סוד' as 'mystical significance' rather than literally as 'secret,' which better conveys the kabbalistic connotation in this context. In Jewish mystical literature, 'sod' typically refers to the deepest, esoteric level of interpretation.

[3] The phrase 'שיאמר האבל' specifically indicates that what follows would be the text of the Tziduk HaDin prayer to be recited by the mourner, though the prayer text itself is not included in this excerpt.

[4] This line expresses the theological concept of 'tzidduk hadin' (justification of the divine judgment),

[i] The word 'katapayyim' (literally 'shoulders') refers specifically to the pallbearers who carry the deceased on their shoulders, reflecting the traditional Jewish practice of shoulder-bearing the deceased rather than using a wheeled conveyance.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 17, Discourse 3 — The text refers to an earlier section (Ch. 17) that explains how these seven circuits provide comfort to the deceased's soul and have kabbalistic significance for its journey. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 30, Discourse 5 — This reference provides additional mystical interpretations for the hakafot ritual, particularly how they correspond to the seven lower sefirot and provide protection for the soul's journey. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21, Discourse 2 — This reference explains the mystical significance of the Tziduk HaDin prayer that is mentioned as preceding the hakafot ritual in the cemetery.

[iii] Tziduk HaDin (literally 'Justification of the Divine Judgment') refers to a prayer recited at Jewish funerals where mourners affirm the righteousness of God's judgment even in death. The term 'סוד' (sod) here indicates that the text will explain not just the practical procedure but the mystical or kabbalistic significance of this ritual.

[iv] The text refers to different sections of Ma'avar Yabok itself, indicating that the book has a complex structure with multiple 'discourses' (מאמרים) divided into chapters. This self-referential organization is typical of comprehensive reference works of the period.

[v] This specifies that the Tziduk HaDin prayer should be recited specifically by the mourner (אבל), who would typically be a close relative of the deceased. This reflects the Jewish practice of assigning specific ritual roles to different participants in the funeral process.

[vi] Cf. Tziduk HaDin — The text references specific chapters within Ma'avar Yabok where the mystical significance and proper procedures for reciting this funeral prayer are detailed. This cross-reference indicates the text's systematic organization, with different aspects of death rituals being treated in specific, cross-referenced sections. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's internal chapter structure — The text contains internal cross-references to other sections of the book, demonstrating how Ma'avar Yabok was designed as a comprehensive reference work with interconnected sections. This shows that the author intended readers to move between different sections to gain complete understanding of specific rituals.

[vii] This line marks the beginning of the Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) prayer recited during Jewish funeral services. The phrase comes from Nehemiah 9:33 and is used to acknowledge God's righteousness even in moments of suffering and loss. In Ma'avar Yabok, this prayer is specifically mentioned as part of the burial ritual, to be recited at the graveside after the seven hakafot (circuits) around the bier have been completed.

[viii] Cf. Nehemiah 9:33 — The original biblical source for this phrase, where the people of Israel acknowledge God's justice even during their suffering. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse becomes the

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתְּגַדֵּר פִּרְצוֹתֵינוּ וּפִרְצוֹת עַמְּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּרַחֲמִים: עיין בפרק ל״ג מאמר ה׳[i][ii]

May it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers, that You repair our breaches[1] and the breaches of Your people Israel with mercy.[2] See Chapter 33 of Discourse 5. 4030R

אחר צדוק הדין וההקפות וכשבאים הארון על זרועותיהם[iii] לשים אותו בקבר יאמרו שיר של פגעים סי׳ צ״א ויהי נועם. וכל אחד כשזורק העפר בקבר יאמר ג״פ והוא רחום וגו׳ והוא חסד גדול להחליש ראשי המשחית הנזכרים בפסוק[iv] ואם יאמרוהו כל הקהל בקול מה טוב כי בזה מקילים מעליו כח המלקות מחבוט

After the Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) and the Hakafot (ritual circuits), when they carry the coffin on their arms to place it in the grave, they should recite Shir Shel Pegaim (Song of Afflictions, Psalm 91)[3] and "Vihi Noam" (May the pleasantness [of the Lord]). And each person, when throwing earth into the grave, should recite three times "Ve-Hu Rachum"[4] (And He, being merciful), etc. This is a great kindness that weakens the "heads of the destroyer" mentioned in the verse. 4035R 4040R

a fundamental Jewish response to death. By affirming God's righteousness even in the face of loss, the mourner acknowledges divine justice while still experiencing grief. The prayer creates a ritual framework for accepting mortality within a religious context, allowing mourners to express their pain while maintaining faith in divine wisdom.

[1]The metaphor of 'breaches' (פרצות) has multiple layers in Jewish thought. Physically, it refers to broken walls that leave a city vulnerable to attack. Spiritually, it represents moral or religious failures that leave individuals or communities vulnerable to spiritual harm. In the context of funeral prayers, it specifically refers to the wound or vulnerability created by death in the fabric of the community.

[2]The prayer follows the Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment), which acknowledges God's justice even in death. This prayer then pivots to request mercy, reflecting the Jewish theological balance between divine justice and compassion.

[3]Psalm 91 was known in rabbinic tradition as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions or Song against Demons) because it was believed to have special protective properties against harmful spiritual forces.

[4]This refers to Psalm 78:38, which begins 'But He, being compassionate, forgave their iniquity and did not destroy them.' This verse was considered particularly powerful for spiritual protection.

opening line of the funeral prayer, transferring its context from national to personal loss. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21, Discourse 2 — As mentioned in memory note 838, Ma'avar Yabok discusses the Tzidduk HaDin prayer in Chapter 21 of Discourse 2, explaining its kabbalistic significance. The prayer appears here in the practical section as part of the actual burial ritual. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 26, Discourse 5 — As mentioned in memory note 838, Ma'avar Yabok discusses the specific laws of Tzidduk HaDin in Chapter 26 of Discourse 5, showing the book's integration of mystical concepts with practical legal guidance.

[i]The text includes a self-reference to Chapter 33 of Discourse 5, which appears to elaborate on the theological significance of this prayer. This cross-referencing system is typical of Ma'avar Yabok, which functions both as a practical ritual guide and a theoretical explanation of the cosmic significance of these rituals.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 33 of Discourse 5 — The prayer references this chapter for deeper explanation of how mourning rituals create spiritual protection for both the deceased and the community. The phrase 'repair our breaches' refers to the spiritual vulnerability created by death, which the author believes can affect the entire community unless properly addressed through ritual.

[iii]The Hebrew phrase emphasizes that the coffin should be carried by hand rather than using carts or other mechanical means, following traditional Jewish burial practices that honor the deceased through personal effort.

[iv]This phrase refers to destructive spiritual forces believed to have authority over the deceased. The recitation of 'Ve-Hu Rachum' is understood to neutralize these forces through divine mercy.

הקבר:[i] עיין בפרק י״ח מאמר ג׳:[ii]

And if the entire congregation recites it aloud, how good it is,[1] for through this they lighten the force of the lashes from "Chibut HaKever" (the Beating of the Grave) for the deceased. See Chapter 18 of Discourse 3. 4045R

וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר עָוֹן וְלֹא
יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ וְלֹא
3795 יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ ג׳ פעמים: וְנָחֲךָ
יְיָ תָּמִיד[iii] וְהַשְׂבִּיעַ בְּצַחֲצָחוֹת
נַפְשֶׁךָ וַעֲצָמוֹתֶיךָ יַחֲלִיץ וְהָיִיתָ
כְּגַן רָוֶה וּכְמוֹצָא מַיִם אֲשֶׁר לֹא
יְכַזְּבוּ מֵימָיו: כִּי יַעֲמֹד לִימִין
3800 אֶבְיוֹן לְהוֹשִׁיעַ מִשּׁוֹפְטֵי נַפְשׁוֹ:
מִגְדַּל עֹז שֵׁם יְיָ[iv] בּוֹ יָרוּץ צַדִּיק
וְנִשְׂגָּב: וְיָשַׁב עַמִּי בִּנְוֵה שָׁלוֹם
וּבְמִשְׁכְּנוֹת מִבְטָחִים וּבִמְנוּחוֹת
שַׁאֲנַנוֹת:[v] וִיהִי נֹעַם יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ
3805 עָלֵינוּ וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֵינוּ כּוֹנְנָה עָלֵינוּ
וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֵינוּ כּוֹנְנֵהוּ: יְיָ יִגְמֹר
בַּעֲדֵנוּ יְיָ חַסְדְּךָ לְעוֹלָם מַעֲשֵׂי

"And He, being merciful, forgives iniquity and does not destroy; He frequently turns away His anger[2] and does not arouse all His wrath" [repeat this verse three times]. "And the LORD will guide you continually, and satisfy your soul in parched places,[3] and strengthen your bones; and you shall be like a watered garden, and like a spring of water, whose waters never fail." "For He stands at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who condemn his soul." "The name of the LORD is a strong tower; the righteous runs into it and is safe." "And My people shall dwell in a peaceful habitation, in secure dwellings, and in quiet resting places."[4] "May the pleasantness of the LORD our God be upon us, and establish the work of our hands upon us; yes, establish the work of 4050R 4055R 4060R

[1] The text emphasizes communal participation in this ritual, suggesting that the collective spiritual power of the community provides greater protection for the deceased.

[2] The Hebrew והרבה להשיב אפו literally means 'He abundantly turns back His anger,' suggesting God's repeated and generous restraint rather than a one-time action.

[3] The term צחצחות (tzachtzachot) specifically refers to extremely dry, parched places, creating a stark contrast with the following imagery of a well-watered garden. In mystical contexts, this can represent spiritual drought transformed into abundance.

[4] The Hebrew text uses three parallel phrases to describe peaceful afterlife abodes, creating a poetic triplet that emphasizes divine protection and serenity.

[i] This term (literally 'the Beating of the Grave') refers to a concept in Jewish mysticism where the soul undergoes a purification process after burial. The recitation of protective verses is believed to mitigate this suffering.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 91 — This psalm is considered to have special protective properties against harmful spiritual forces and is specifically recommended for recitation during funeral rituals to safeguard the deceased's soul. | Cf. Vihi Noam (Psalm 90:17) — This prayer, beginning with 'May the pleasantness of the Lord our God be upon us,' is recited at transitional moments and is believed to provide spiritual protection. | Cf. Ve-Hu Rachum (Psalm 78:38) — This verse 'And He, being merciful, forgives iniquity and does not destroy; He frequently turns His anger away and does not arouse all His wrath' is believed to have protective power when recited three times while throwing earth into the grave. | Cf. Chibut HaKever — This refers to a Jewish mystical concept of a painful process that occurs after burial where the soul is judged. These ritual recitations are believed to mitigate this suffering for the deceased. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This reference directs readers to Chapter 18 of Discourse 3, which presumably contains more detailed explanations about the spiritual significance of these burial practices.

[iii] This verse from Isaiah uses imagery of a well-watered garden to represent spiritual renewal and divine care. In the context of burial rituals, it suggests hope for the soul's refreshment after death.

[iv] The metaphor of God's name as a protective fortress (migdal oz) is particularly meaningful in burial contexts, suggesting the deceased's soul can find refuge in divine protection during its journey.

[v] This verse's threefold description of peaceful habitation (naveh shalom), secure dwellings (mishkenot mivtachim), and quiet resting places (menuchot sha'ananot) creates a powerful image of the soul's peaceful repose after death.

יָדֶיךָ אַל תֶּרֶף:[i] our hands." "The LORD will fulfill His purpose for us; Your steadfast love, O LORD, endures forever; do not forsake the work of Your hands."[1] 4065R

ויש מקומות שאומרים כלם אחר ששמוהו בקבר:[iii][ii] And there are places where they all say,[2] after they have placed him in the grave:[3] 3810

אֲסִיפַת שָׁלוֹם תְּהֶיה אֲסִיפָתו:[iv] נגד בחינת נשמתה שבו[vi][v] May his gathering be a gathering of peace:[A] corresponding to the aspect of the neshamah within him.[B] 4070R

[A]Or: "May his ingathering be in peace" — The term 'asifah' (gathering) is a euphemism for death in Hebrew, with connotations of being gathered to one's ancestors. This alternative preserves the euphemistic nature while using a slightly different English phrasing.

[B]Or: "corresponding to the highest soul-level (neshamah) within him" — This translation

[1]The final phrase 'אל תרף' (al teref) can be translated as 'do not forsake' or 'do not abandon,' but also carries connotations of 'do not loosen your grip' or 'do not let go,' emphasizing God's continued care and involvement.

[2]The Hebrew "כלם" (kulam) refers to all the people present at the burial, emphasizing the communal nature of this ritual prayer.

[3]The text will proceed to list a series of prayers that should be recited at this specific moment in the burial ritual. This timing is significant as it represents the final transition of the deceased's physical body into its resting place.

[i]Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This verse is traditionally recited three times during burial rituals as indicated by the instruction 'ג' פעמים' (three times). In Ma'avar Yabok, it's specifically recommended when throwing earth into the grave, believed to have protective power against negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse offers hope for the soul's refreshment and strengthening after death, contrasting the 'parched places' of spiritual struggle with the 'watered garden' of divine restoration. | Cf. Psalm 109:31 — In burial contexts, this would be understood as God defending the deceased's soul against spiritual accusers during its judgment, providing divine advocacy during this vulnerable transition. | Cf. Proverbs 18:10 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this imagery of divine protection would be particularly meaningful for the deceased's soul, suggesting it can find refuge in God's name during its journey. | Cf. Isaiah 32:18 — This verse is especially appropriate in burial contexts as it describes the peaceful rest awaiting the righteous soul, with the 'secure dwellings' and 'quiet resting places' representing the soul's tranquil abode in the afterlife. | Cf. Psalm 90:17 — In the context of burial rituals, this can be understood as a prayer that the deceased's good deeds in life be established and accepted by God, creating lasting merit for their soul. | Cf. Psalm 138:8 — For burial rites, this verse offers reassurance that God's love for the deceased continues beyond death and that He will not abandon them, completing His divine purpose for their soul.

[ii]This passage appears in the section of Ma'avar Yabok dealing with burial rituals, specifically identifying regional variations in funeral practices. The phrase introduces a prayer to be recited collectively by all present after the deceased has been placed in the grave.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 18, Discourse 3 — This passage connects to earlier discussions in Ma'avar Yabok about proper burial practices. The author presents regional variations in ritual practice, acknowledging that different communities might recite different prayers at the same moment in the burial process. | Cf. Zohar III:70b — The prayers that follow this introduction likely relate to the kabbalistic understanding, found in the Zohar, that specific recitations at the graveside help guide the soul on its journey and provide it with peace.

[iv]The term 'asifah' (gathering) is a euphemism for death in Jewish tradition, based on biblical phrases like 'being gathered to one's people' (Genesis 25:8). This gentle euphemism is typical of Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a transition rather than an ending.

[v]This phrase refers to the kabbalistic concept that the human soul has three primary components: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). The prayer addresses specifically the neshamah, which is the highest and most divine aspect that returns directly to God after death.

[vi]Cf. Genesis 25:8 — The prayer deliberately echoes the biblical language used for the peaceful

	נגד בחינת הנשמה שבו[iii] ii יְהִי רְבִיצַת שָׁלוֹם[i] רִבִיצָתוֹ:	May his resting place be a peaceful rest:[A] corresponding to the aspect of the neshamah within him[1]
3815	נגד הרוח[vi] v מְחִיצַת שָׁלוֹם תְּהֵא מְחִיצָתוֹ:	"May his partition be a partition of peace"[2]—corresponding to the ruach (spirit)

explicitly identifies the neshamah as the highest of the three primary soul levels in Jewish mysticism, providing important context that might not be clear to readers unfamiliar with Kabbalistic terminology.

[A]Or: "His place of repose shall be a peaceful resting" — This alternate translation emphasizes the noun form 'place of repose' rather than using 'resting place' and slightly varies the wording while maintaining the meaning. This might be preferable in contexts where a more formal or poetic tone is desired.

[1]According to the kabbalistic framework in Ma'avar Yabok, each component of the soul requires its own form of rest after death. This particular prayer focuses on the neshamah (highest soul aspect), requesting appropriate peaceful rest for this spiritual element. Other prayers in this sequence would address the nefesh (vital soul) and ruach (spirit) components.

[2]The term 'mechitzah' (מְחִיצָה) literally means 'partition' or 'divider,' but in this context refers to the soul's spiritual compartment or dwelling place in the afterlife. Each level of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) is understood to have its own 'mechitzah' or spiritual domain.

death of the patriarchs. The term 'gathering' (asifah) in the Bible is specifically used for the righteous who die peacefully and are 'gathered' to their ancestors. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 3 — This line refers to the kabbalistic concept that the human soul has three primary components: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). The prayer specifically addresses the neshamah, which is the highest and most divine aspect of the soul that returns directly to God after death.

[i]The term 'revitzat' (רְבִיצַת) comes from the root רבץ (r-b-tz) meaning to lie down or rest. In this context, it refers to a spiritual resting place.

[ii]This phrase refers to the neshamah level of the soul, which is the highest of the three primary soul components (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) in Kabbalistic thought. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's burial prayers, this specifically indicates that this particular prayer addresses the highest aspect of the deceased's soul.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok root.2.1.0.2.115 — This reference provides context about the 'gathering of peace' concept that appears just before this passage. Together they form a sequence of short prayers addressing different aspects of the soul's peaceful transition after death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok root.2.1.0.2.117 — This reference provides the next prayer in this sequence, continuing the pattern of addressing different aspects of the soul's peaceful transition after death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok root.4 — This reference explains the theological framework behind this prayer's specific focus on the neshamah aspect of the soul, as part of a comprehensive system addressing each soul component's unique journey after death.

[iv]This is part of a series of blessings recited at a Jewish burial, specifically after placing the body in the grave. Each blessing refers to a different aspect of the soul's resting place, with this one addressing the ruach (middle level of the soul).

[v]This explanatory note indicates that this particular blessing corresponds to the ruach (spirit), which in Kabbalah is the middle level of the three-part soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah). The preceding blessing addressed the neshamah (highest soul level) and the following one will address the nefesh (vital soul).

[vi]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, earlier sections on soul structure — Throughout Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia consistently presents the soul as having three primary components: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (highest divine soul). This passage is part of a ritual formula that addresses each level separately, providing each with its own blessing for peaceful repose in the afterlife. | Cf. Zohar — This threefold blessing structure reflects the Zoharic concept of the soul's tripartite nature, where each component (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) has its own spiritual trajectory and afterlife experience. The Zohar teaches that these soul parts separate at death but remain connected, each dwelling in an appropriate spiritual realm according to its nature.

שְׁכִיבַת שָׁלוֹם תְּהֵא שְׁכִיבָתוֹ: נגד הנפש[i][ii]

May his lying down be a lying down of peace:[A] Corresponding to the nefesh [vital soul][B]

הִנֵּה מָכוֹן. הִנֵּה מָלוֹן. הִנֵּה מְנוּחָה:[iii] נגד הגוף וכחותיו[iv][v]

Behold a dwelling place, behold a lodging, behold a resting place:[1] corresponding to the body and its powers.[2]

דאינון הבלא דגרמי[vi] ועצבונא

which are the breath of the bones[3] and the sadness of

[A] Or: "May his rest be a peaceful rest" — This alternate translation conveys the same meaning with more natural English phrasing, though it loses some of the repetition present in the original Hebrew which emphasizes the state of 'lying down.'

[B] Or: "For the benefit of the nefesh [vital soul]" — The Hebrew 'neged' can sometimes indicate 'for the benefit of' rather than simply 'corresponding to,' suggesting that this prayer is intended to benefit or protect the nefesh specifically.

[1] The Hebrew uses a threefold repetition of the word 'הִנֵּה' (behold/here is) followed by three different terms for places of residence, creating a poetic progression from a formal structure (מָכוֹן/dwelling place) to a temporary lodging (מָלוֹן) to a final place of rest (מְנוּחָה). This liturgical formula appears to be part of the burial service, acknowledging the grave as the body's final resting place.

[2] The Hebrew 'נגד הגוף וכחותיו' is a brief explanatory note that follows this poetic declaration. It indicates that these three dwelling terms specifically relate to the physical body and its faculties, distinguishing this from other parts of the burial liturgy that might address the soul. In Jewish mystical thought, the body retains significance even after death, as it awaits resurrection.

[3] The term 'הבלא דגרמי' appears frequently in kabbalistic texts to describe a subtle spiritual vapor or essence that remains with the bones after death. This is not ordinary breath but a residual spiritual connection.

[i] The Hebrew indicates that this blessing is specifically directed toward the nefesh (vital soul), which in kabbalistic thought is the lowest of the three soul components. Unlike the higher soul aspects (ruach and neshamah), the nefesh remains more closely connected to the physical body after death and requires specific comfort and protection.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, earlier passages on the three-part soul — This line is part of a sequence of blessings corresponding to each level of the soul. The preceding lines likely address the higher soul components (neshamah and ruach), while this line specifically addresses the nefesh, which is considered the lowest component that remains closest to the body after death. | Cf. Biblical usage of 'shechivah' (lying down) as euphemism for death — The text deliberately employs this traditional euphemism while transforming it into a positive blessing by adding 'of peace' (shalom). This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's consistent approach of reframing death as a peaceful transition rather than something fearful.

[iii] This threefold declaration appears to be part of a burial ritual in Ma'avar Yabok, likely recited after placing the deceased in the grave. The three terms (מָכוֹן/dwelling place, מָלוֹן/lodging, and מְנוּחָה/resting place) represent a poetic progression from temporary abode to final rest.

[iv] This phrase explains that the preceding three terms correspond to the physical body and its faculties/powers. In kabbalistic thought, the body continues to have significance even after death, particularly as the vessel that will be resurrected in the messianic era.

[v] Cf. Ecclesiastes 12:5 — The threefold formula in Ma'avar Yabok echoes Ecclesiastes' concept of the grave as the 'eternal home' of the body, but with a more positive framing as a place of rest rather than mere finality. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage appears to be part of a larger ritual framework in Ma'avar Yabok that systematically addresses different aspects of the human being (body, nefesh, ruach, and neshamah) at burial, with parallel formulaic declarations for each component.

[vi] This Aramaic phrase literally means "breath/vapor of the bones" and refers to a subtle spiritual essence that remains with the physical remains. In kabbalistic thought, this is one of the aspects of the body that retains a connection to the departed soul.

דבישרא[i] ומנוח״ה לעצם של התחיה:[ii] ומסיימין[iii]

the flesh[1] and rest for the bone of resurrection.[2] And they conclude:

וְיֹאמְרוּ כָּל קְהַל עֲדָתוֹ יָבֹא שָׁלוֹם
3825 יָבֹא שָׁלוֹם יָבֹא שָׁלוֹם[iv] יָנוּחַ
עַל קִבּוּרָתוֹ: מַלְאֲכֵי חֶסֶד
הַמְמֻנִּים עַל שַׁעֲרֵי הַחֶסֶד הֵם
יֵצְאוּ לִקְרָאתוֹ וְיֹאמְרוּ לוֹ שָׁלוֹם
בּאֲךָ: מַלְאֲכֵי רַחֲמִים הַמְמֻנִּים
3830 עַל שַׁעֲרֵי הָרַחֲמִים הֵם יָצְאוּ
לִקְרָאתוֹ וְיֹאמְרוּ לוֹ שָׁלוֹם בּאֲךָ:
מַלְאֲכֵי הַחֵן הַמְמוּנִים עַל שַׁעֲרֵי
הַחֵן הֵם יֵצְאוּ לִקְרָאתוֹ וְיֹאמְרוּ
לוֹ שָׁלוֹם בּאֲךָ: וְאַתָּה לֵךְ לְקֵץ
3835 וְתָנוּחַ וְתַעֲמֹד לְגֹרָלְךָ לְקֵץ

And all the congregation of his assembly[3] shall say: "May peace come, may peace come, may peace come, may he rest upon his grave."[4] The angels of loving- 4085R
kindness appointed over the gates of loving-kindness, they shall go forth to meet him and say to him, "Peace upon your arrival."[5] The angels of mercy appointed over the gates of mercy, they shall go forth to meet him and say to him, "Peace upon your ar- 4090R
rival." The angels of grace appointed over the gates of grace, they shall go forth to meet him and say to him, "Peace upon your arrival." And you, go to the end and rest,[6] and you shall stand up for your portion at

[1]The poetic phrase 'עצבונא דבישרא' personifies the decomposing flesh as experiencing sorrow or pain, reflecting the Jewish theological view that decomposition is part of the atonement process for the body.

[2]This refers to the luz bone that, according to Jewish tradition, cannot be destroyed and serves as the seed from which the body will be reconstituted at resurrection. The use of the term 'rest' (מנוחה) is significant, suggesting that this bone is in a state of peaceful waiting rather than total death.

[3]The Hebrew phrase 'כָּל קְהַל עֲדָתוֹ' contains a redundancy, as both 'kahal' and 'edah' mean 'congregation.' This doubling emphasizes the communal aspect of the prayer and suggests that both the earthly community and the heavenly assembly are united in this declaration.

[4]The Hebrew 'יָנוּחַ עַל קִבּוּרָתוֹ' literally means 'may he rest upon his burial place.' This reflects the Jewish belief that the soul maintains a connection to the body even after death, hovering near the grave for a period before ascending higher. This concept is elaborated in kabbalistic texts like the Zohar.

[5]The phrase 'שָׁלוֹם בּאֲךָ' (peace upon your arrival) echoes the traditional greeting offered to guests in this world, suggesting continuity between earthly hospitality and heavenly reception. The repetition by three different groups of angels indicates the soul's welcome at successive levels of the spiritual realms.

[6]This is a direct quotation from Daniel 12:13, where the angel tells Daniel about his ultimate fate. By applying this verse to the deceased, the prayer assures them that like Daniel, they will rest

[i]This Aramaic phrase literally means "sadness/pain of the flesh" and refers to the decomposition process of the body, poetically described as the flesh experiencing sorrow as it returns to dust.

[ii]This refers to the rabbinic concept of the luz bone (sometimes identified as the coccyx), which was believed to be indestructible and would serve as the seed from which the body would be reconstituted at the time of resurrection. The word מנוח״ה (rest) has the letters of the word נחמ״ה (comfort) rearranged, suggesting that the indestructible bone provides comfort through the promise of future resurrection.

[iii]Cf. Ezekiel 37 — This passage draws on Ezekiel's vision of resurrection, where breath (הבל) enters the dry bones to restore them to life. The text establishes three components involved in the body's fate: the breath/vapor of bones, the decay/sadness of flesh, and the preserved bone (luz) that will serve as the foundation for resurrection. | Cf. Midrash Genesis Rabbah 28:3 — This reference to 'the bone of resurrection' (עצם של התחיה) alludes to the rabbinic concept of the luz bone, described in Genesis Rabbah as an indestructible bone from which the body will be reconstituted at resurrection. This concept is extensively discussed elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as a physical connection between death and future resurrection.

[iv]The threefold repetition of 'may peace come' has mystical significance. In Kabbalah, tripling a phrase intensifies its spiritual power and connects it to the three levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, and neshamah). It also recalls the Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26) which is structured as three blessings.

הַיָּמִין:[i] בִּלַּע הַמָּוֶת לָנֶצַח וּמָחָה
יְיָ אֱלֹהִים דִּמְעָה מֵעַל כָּל פָּנִים
וְחֶרְפַּת עַמּוֹ יָסִיר מֵעַל כָּל הָאָרֶץ
כִּי יְיָ דִּבֶּר: יִחְיוּ מֵתֶיךָ נְבֵלָתִי
3840 יְקוּמוּן הָקִיצוּ וְרַנְּנוּ שֹׁכְנֵי עָפָר
כִּי טַל אוֹרוֹת טַלֶּךָ[ii] וְאֶרֶץ רְפָאִים
תַּפִּיל:[iii] וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר עָוֹן
וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ
וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ: כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה
3845 תְּהַלֵּל יָהּ הַלְלוּיָהּ: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ
אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וּבָרוּךְ שֵׁם
כְּבוֹדוֹ לְעוֹלָם וְיִמָּלֵא כְבוֹדוֹ אֶת
הָאָרֶץ אָמֵן וְאָמֵן:[iv]

the end of days. He will swallow up death forever, 4095R
and the Lord God will wipe away tears from all faces,
and the reproach of His people He will remove from
all the earth, for the LORD has spoken. Your dead
shall live, my corpse, they shall arise. Awake and
sing, you who dwell in the dust, for your dew is like 4100R
the dew of light,[1] and the earth shall cast out the
departed. And He, being merciful, pardons iniquity
and does not destroy, and frequently turns away His
anger and does not stir up all His wrath. Let ev-
ery soul praise the LORD,[2] Hallelujah. Blessed is 4105R
the LORD God, the God of Israel, and blessed is
His glorious name forever, and may His glory fill the
earth,[3] Amen and Amen.

until the time of resurrection, when they will 'stand up for their portion'—receive their reward in the World to Come.

[1]The 'dew of light' (טַל אוֹרוֹת) is a powerful resurrection metaphor. Just as dew revives wilted plants, this celestial dew is believed to revive the dead. In kabbalah, this dew is associated with the divine attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness) flowing down from higher spiritual realms.

[2]The Hebrew 'כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל יָהּ' makes a wordplay between 'נְשָׁמָה' (soul/breath) and the verb 'תְּהַלֵּל' (praise), suggesting that the very essence of the soul's existence is to praise God. This verse affirms that the soul continues this divine purpose even after death.

[3]This concluding blessing is a standard liturgical formula that appears at the end of sections in Psalms. Its inclusion here connects the individual's death to the larger cosmic purpose of God's glory filling the world, framing personal loss within a universal, redemptive context.

[i]The phrase 'לְקֵץ הַיָּמִין' (at the end of days/right end) has eschatological significance, referring to the messianic era and resurrection of the dead. The term 'ימין' (right) has positive connotations in Jewish thought, representing the side of mercy and reward, as opposed to 'שמאל' (left), which is associated with judgment.

[ii]The 'dew of lights' (טַל אוֹרוֹת) is interpreted in rabbinic tradition as the 'dew of resurrection' that will revive the dead. The Talmud (Chagigah 12b) associates this celestial dew with the light created on the first day of creation that God stored away for the righteous in the future world.

[iii]The Hebrew word 'רְפָאִים' (refaim) has a dual meaning: it can refer to the departed/shades in the underworld or to healing/physicians. This creates a wordplay suggesting that the earth will 'drop' or 'cast out' those who have died, effectively 'healing' death by releasing its captives during resurrection.

[iv]Cf. Daniel 12:13 — This verse is addressed to the deceased, assuring them that they will arise at the resurrection of the dead. The phrase 'end of days' (קץ הימין) is a messianic reference to the time of redemption. This offers consolation that death is not final. | Cf. Isaiah 25:8 — This prophetic verse reinforces the Jewish belief in resurrection and the end of death. Its inclusion in a burial prayer provides comfort by pointing to a future time when death will be permanently overcome. | Cf. Isaiah 26:19 — This verse describes resurrection through the metaphor of dew, which in rabbinic thought is connected to the 'dew of resurrection' (טל תחיה) that will revive the dead. The passage offers hope that those buried will eventually rise again. | Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This verse is recited to invoke divine mercy for the deceased. In this context, it serves as a plea that God will forgive any sins of the departed and treat them with compassion rather than judgment. | Cf. Psalm 150:6 — This verse connects the soul (נשמה) with praise of God, suggesting that even after death, the soul continues to praise God in the heavenly realm. It affirms the soul's immortality and ongoing spiritual existence. | Cf. Zohar — The tripartite structure of angels greeting the deceased reflects kabbalistic cosmology where the soul encounters different angelic beings as it ascends through heavenly realms. Each set of angels represents a different divine attribute (Chesed/loving-kindness, Rachamim/mercy, and Chen/grace) that will assist the soul's journey after death.

טעם השלכת העפר על המת ג׳
3850 או ה׳ פעמים.[i] ולמה אין מושיטין
זה לזה הכלי[ii] עיין בפרק כ״ז
מאמר ב׳ ובפרק הנ״ל יש ג״כ
סוד קבורת המתים[iii] בפרק
י״ט מאמר ג׳ יתבאר מה יכוונו
3855 בנטילת ידיהם אחר הקבורה ואז
יאמרו:[iv]

The reason for throwing earth on the deceased three or five times, and why the tool [shovel] is not passed from one person to another, is explained in Chapter 27 of the Second Discourse. That same chapter also contains the mystical significance[1] of burying the dead. Chapter 19 of the Third Discourse explains the proper intention (kavvanah)[2] for washing one's hands after burial, at which point they should recite: 4110R 4115R

תִּפֹּל עֲלֵיהֶם אֵימָתָה וָפַחַד[v] בִּגְדֹל
זְרוֹעֲךָ יִדְמוּ כָּאָבֶן[vi] עַד יַעֲבֹר
עַמְּךָ יְיָ[vii] עַד יַעֲבֹר עַם זוּ קָנִיתָ:
3860 וְהִתְקַדִּשְׁתֶּם וִהְיִיתֶם קְדֹשִׁים כִּי
קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם:[viii]

May terror and dread fall upon them;[3] by the greatness of Your arm may they be still as stone[4]—until Your people cross over,[5] O LORD, until the people whom You have acquired cross over. And you shall sanctify yourselves and be holy, for I, the LORD your 4120R

[1]The Hebrew term 'sod' literally means 'secret' but in kabbalistic contexts refers specifically to the deepest, mystical level of interpretation, which is why I've translated it as 'mystical significance.'
[2]I've included the Hebrew term 'kavvanah' in parentheses as it is a technical term in Jewish mysticism referring to the specific spiritual focus and intention that should accompany ritual actions.
[3]In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's post-burial ritual, 'them' refers not to human enemies (as in the original Exodus context) but to harmful spiritual forces that might follow mourners from the cemetery.
[4]This phrase evokes powerful imagery of complete immobilization, suggesting that the hand-washing ritual effectively neutralizes any negative spiritual influences that might have attached themselves to mourners in the cemetery.
[5]The concept of 'crossing over' (ma'avar) is central to the entire book, which uses Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River as a metaphor for the soul's transition between worlds. Here, it refers to the mourners' safe return from the cemetery to normal life.

[i]The specific numbers three and five have mystical significance in Jewish tradition. Three represents balance and stability (connecting to the three Patriarchs), while five connects to the five books of the Torah.
[ii]This refers to the tradition of not passing the burial shovel directly from one person to another, but rather placing it on the ground for the next person to pick up, which is believed to prevent the transmission of death's spiritual impact.
[iii]The word 'sod' (secret/mystery) indicates the mystical dimension of burial practices beyond their practical aspects, suggesting kabbalistic interpretations of these rituals.
[iv]Cf. Chapter 27, Second Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — The text refers readers to this section for the deeper explanation of these burial customs, suggesting that there are both practical halakhic rules and mystical reasons behind these practices. | Cf. Chapter 19, Third Discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — This cross-reference indicates that proper hand washing after burial requires specific kavvanah (mystical intention), not just physical cleansing, revealing how Ma'avar Yabok integrates practical ritual with mystical significance.
[v]This phrase from Exodus 15:16 (part of the Song at the Sea) is used here to invoke divine protection against harmful spiritual entities that mourners might encounter in or bring back from the cemetery. The 'them' refers metaphorically to these negative spiritual forces.
[vi]The Hebrew 'yidmu ka-aven' (be still as stone) uses the imagery of being rendered motionless like stone, suggesting the complete neutralization of harmful spiritual forces that might follow mourners from the cemetery.
[vii]The verb 'ya'avor' (cross over) connects directly to the title of Ma'avar Yabok (Crossing of the Yabok), reinforcing the book's central metaphor of crossing over safely from one realm to another, in this case from the cemetery (domain of death) back to the world of the living.
[viii]Cf. Exodus 15:16 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is specifically recited during hand-washing after returning from the cemetery. The parallel is significant—just as the Israelites crossed through water to safety while their enemies were rendered powerless, the mourners use water to ritually

God, am holy.[1]

עוד יוסיף ויאמר[i][ii] He shall further add and say:[2]

רִבּוֹן כָּל הָעוֹלָמִים מַלֵּא יָדָיו והוא מלשון מקום ר״ל מקומו
3865 בגן עדן[iii] מְבָרְכוֹתֶיךָ וּבָרְכֵנוּ אֲבִינוּ כֻּלָּנוּ כְּאֶחָד בְּאוֹר פָּנֶיךָ וּמִבְּרָכָתְךָ יְבֹרַךְ בֵּית עַבְדְּךָ לְעוֹלָם: כִּי אֹרֶךְ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם יוֹסִיפוּ לָנוּ עִם כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל
3870 אָמֵן:[iv]

Master of all Worlds,[3] fill his hands—this being an expression referring to place, meaning his place in 4125R
the Garden of Eden—with Your blessings, and bless us, our Father, all of us as one,[4] with the light of Your countenance. And from Your blessing may the house of Your servant be blessed forever. For length of days and years of life and peace may be added to 4130R
us, together with all Israel.[5] Amen.

ולא ינגבו ידיהם במפה.[v] וטוב And they should not dry their hands with a

[1]The juxtaposition of these two verses creates a powerful ritual framework: the first verse (from Exodus) provides protection during transition, while the second verse (from Leviticus) establishes the purpose of ritual purification—to restore the state of holiness that enables continued relationship with the divine after contact with death.

[2]This type of liturgical instruction appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok and similar ritual manuals, indicating the continuation of a ritual sequence. It signals to the prayer leader or funeral officiant to proceed with additional prayers after completing the previous elements of the service.

[3]This is a common epithet for God in Jewish liturgy, particularly in prayers with mystical overtones. It emphasizes God's sovereignty over multiple spiritual realms, not just the physical world.

[4]This shifts from focusing on the deceased to the community of mourners, a characteristic transition in Jewish memorial prayers that addresses both the spiritual journey of the departed and the continued life of the bereaved.

[5]The conclusion of the prayer expands from the immediate mourners to the entire Jewish people, a common feature in Jewish liturgy that emphasizes communal solidarity even in moments of personal grief.

separate themselves from death and seek protection from harmful spiritual forces associated with the cemetery. | Cf. Leviticus 11:44 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse emphasizes the importance of ritual purification after contact with death. The washing of hands serves as a means of re-establishing holiness and separating oneself from ritual impurity associated with the cemetery. This reflects the book's consistent theme that proper ritual actions have profound spiritual significance, particularly in transitional moments between worlds.

[i]This is a standard liturgical instruction phrase in Ma'avar Yabok that indicates a transition to an additional prayer or text to be recited at a specific point in the funeral ritual.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is a transitional phrase instructing mourners or the burial society members to continue with additional prayers after completing the previous ritual elements at the graveside. | Cf. Siddur (Jewish prayer book) — This type of liturgical instruction is common in Jewish prayer books to indicate when additional prayers should be recited, particularly in sequential ritual contexts.

[iii]The text contains a rabbinic interpretation explaining that the phrase 'fill his hands,' which normally refers to appointment or ordination, is being interpreted here as referring to the deceased's place in the Garden of Eden. This interpretive note is embedded within the prayer itself.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 21:5-7 — The prayer draws on the royal blessing psalm to express hope for divine blessings in the afterlife for the deceased and continued blessings for the mourners. | Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — The reference to blessing and the 'light of Your countenance' echoes the language of the Priestly Blessing, suggesting that this prayer invokes similar divine favor both for the deceased and the living. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fifth Discourse — This prayer follows the pattern established throughout Ma'avar Yabok of simultaneously addressing the afterlife journey of the deceased and the continued wellbeing of the mourners.

[v]This instruction not to dry one's hands with a cloth follows the ritual washing after attending a burial. It differs from normal ritual handwashing where drying is required. The practice symbolizes allowing any spiritual connection to death to dissipate naturally rather than being actively removed.

שישפכו המים על ידיהם ג׳ פעמים:[i][ii]

cloth.[A] And it is good that they pour water over their hands three times.[1]

סדר ההשכבה שנהגו באיזה מקומות[iii] לאומרה בקבורת 3875
המת ובכל ז׳ ימים בביתו אחר התפלה[iv] וכן בכל עת שהולכים לבקר המתים. יאמר מזמור

The Order of Hashkavah (Soul Repose Prayer)[B] that is customarily recited in some places during the burial of the deceased,[C] throughout the seven days of mourning in the home after prayers, and whenever visiting the graves.[2] One should recite the psalm 4135R

[A] Or: "And they should not wipe their hands with a towel" — The Hebrew 'מפה' can be translated as 'towel' rather than 'cloth', and 'ינגבו' can be rendered as 'wipe' rather than 'dry'. This alternate translation maintains the same meaning but uses different English equivalents that might be more natural in some contexts.

[B] Or: "The Rite of Repose" — This alternate translation is more concise and uses Christian-equivalent terminology that might be more familiar to some readers. However, it loses the specific Jewish cultural context of the 'Hashkavah' prayer, which is why I preferred keeping the original Hebrew term with an explanation.

[C] Or: "at the interment" — While 'interment' is a precise equivalent and more concise, I chose the more descriptive phrase to maintain accessibility for readers who might not be familiar with formal funerary terminology.

[1] This ritual washing after visiting a cemetery is called 'netilat yadayim' (washing of hands) and was practiced to remove spiritual impurity (tumah) associated with death. The prescription of exactly three pourings and the prohibition against drying with a cloth distinguishes this ritual from ordinary ritual handwashing before meals or prayer.

[2] The original text uses 'lev'aker ha-metim' (לבקר המתים), literally 'to visit the dead,' which is a common Hebrew expression for visiting cemeteries or graves. I've rendered this as 'visiting the graves' to maintain the meaning while using more natural English.

[i] The instruction to pour water three times reflects the standard Jewish practice for ritual purification, particularly after contact with death or a cemetery. The number three in Jewish mystical thought represents a complete cycle or process, suggesting that this triple pouring completely removes any spiritual impurity associated with death.

[ii] Cf. Masechet Semachot — This instruction is likely based on the concept that one should not retain any connection to the domain of death after leaving the cemetery. Allowing the hands to air dry serves as a symbolic separation between the worlds of the living and the dead. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 19, Discourse 3 — The instruction to pour water three times over the hands follows kabbalistic principles of purification, where the number three represents the complete removal of spiritual impurity associated with contact with death.

[iii] The term 'Hashkavah' (literally 'laying down') refers to a prayer for the repose of the deceased soul. The text indicates this was a regional custom rather than a universal practice at the time of writing.

[iv] This refers to the traditional seven-day mourning period (shiva) when mourners remain at home and receive visitors. The text prescribes reciting this prayer after each of the three daily prayer services during this period.

האזינו כל יושבי חלד:[i][ii] "Give ear, all inhabitants of the world"[1] (Psalm 49): 4140R

(תהלים מט) לַמְנַצֵּחַ לִבְנֵי־קֹרַח 3880
מִזְמוֹר[iii]: שִׁמְעוּ־זֹאת כָּל־הָעַמִּים
הַאֲזִינוּ כָּל־יֹשְׁבֵי חָלֶד: גַּם־בְּנֵי
אָדָם גַּם־בְּנֵי־אִישׁ יַחַד עָשִׁיר
וְאֶבְיוֹן: פִּי יְדַבֵּר חָכְמוֹת וְהָגוּת
לִבִּי תְבוּנוֹת: אַטֶּה לְמָשָׁל אָזְנִי 3885
אֶפְתַּח בְּכִנּוֹר חִידָתִי[iv]: לָמָּה
אִירָא בִּימֵי רָע עֲוֹן עְקֵבַי יְסוֹבֵנִי:
הַבֹּטְחִים עַל־חֵילָם וּבְרֹב עָשְׁרָם
יִתְהַלָּלוּ: אָח לֹא־פָדֹה יִפְדֶּה 4150R
אִישׁ לֹא־יִתֵּן לֵאלֹהִים כָּפְרוֹ[v]: 3890
וְיֵקַר פִּדְיוֹן נַפְשָׁם וְחָדַל לְעוֹלָם:
וְיִחִי־עוֹד לָנֶצַח לֹא יִרְאֶה הַשָּׁחַת:
כִּי יִרְאֶה חֲכָמִים יָמוּתוּ יַחַד כְּסִיל
וָבַעַר יֹאבֵדוּ וְעָזְבוּ לַאֲחֵרִים 4155R
חֵילָם: קִרְבָּם בָּתֵּימוֹ לְעוֹלָם 3895
מִשְׁכְּנֹתָם לְדֹר וָדֹר קָרְאוּ בִשְׁמוֹתָם

(Psalms 49) For the chief musician, for the sons of Korah, a psalm. Hear this, all peoples; give ear, all inhabitants of the world; both low and high, rich and poor together. My mouth shall speak wisdom, and the meditation of my heart shall be understanding. 4145R I will incline my ear to a parable; I will open my riddle with the harp. Why should I fear in days of evil, when the iniquity of my heels surrounds me?[2] Those who trust in their wealth and boast in the abundance of their riches—a brother cannot redeem anyone,[3] he 4150R cannot give to God his ransom. For the redemption of their soul is costly, and it ceases forever. That he should still live forever, and not see corruption. For he sees that wise men die; the fool and the senseless person perish together and leave their wealth 4155R to others. Their inner thought is that their houses shall continue forever, and their dwelling places to

[1] This is a direct quote from the opening verse of Psalm 49. I've provided both the translation and the psalm number in parentheses for clarity, since the original text only references the opening words without explicitly identifying the psalm.

[2] The Hebrew "עֲוֹן עְקֵבַי" (iniquity of my heels) presents interpretive challenges. Some understand it to refer to sins that follow a person like footsteps, while others interpret it as referring to enemies who pursue the psalmist. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would likely be understood as the sins that accompany a person throughout life and are confronted at death.

[3] The original Hebrew "אָח לֹא־פָדֹה יִפְדֶּה אִישׁ" could also be translated as "No one can redeem a brother." Either translation conveys the essential message that no human can rescue another from death through wealth or influence, a theme central to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on individual spiritual preparation.

[i] This is the opening phrase of Psalm 49, which begins 'Give ear, all inhabitants of the world.' The word 'cheled' (חלד) poetically refers to the transient world or temporal existence, making it particularly appropriate for a prayer concerning death.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 49 — Psalm 49 is specifically prescribed as the opening text for the Hashkavah prayer service. This psalm focuses on the transience of human life and wealth, making it particularly appropriate for funeral contexts. Its opening line 'Give ear, all inhabitants of the world' is directly referenced in the Hebrew text. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The Hashkavah prayer appears to be one of several structured liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok for different stages of death rituals. It is specifically designed for recitation at the grave, during the seven days of mourning (shiva), and during subsequent cemetery visits. | Cf. Shiva — The reference to 'seven days' (shiva) indicates this prayer's integration into the traditional Jewish seven-day intensive mourning period following burial. This shows how Ma'avar Yabok incorporates established mourning customs while providing specific liturgical content for them.

[iii] This opening attribution identifies the psalm as being composed for or by the sons of Korah, Levites who served in the Temple. The psalm is introduced as being "For the chief musician," indicating its liturgical use.

[iv] The phrase "I will open my riddle with the harp" suggests that the psalm was originally meant to be accompanied by musical instruments, specifically the kinnor (harp or lyre). This reinforces its function as a liturgical text meant for public performance.

[v] The concept that one "cannot give to God his ransom" establishes a fundamental theological premise that wealth cannot purchase salvation or redemption from death, a theme that resonates strongly with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation rather than material concerns.

עֲלֵי אֲדָמוֹת: וְאָדָם בִּיקָר בַּל־יָלִין
נִמְשָׁל כַּבְּהֵמוֹת נִדְמוּ[i]: זֶה דַרְכָּם
כֵּסֶל לָמוֹ וְאַחֲרֵיהֶם בְּפִיהֶם יִרְצוּ
3900 סֶלָה: כַּצֹּאן לִשְׁאוֹל שַׁתּוּ מָוֶת
יִרְעֵם[ii] וַיִּרְדּוּ בָם יְשָׁרִים לַבֹּקֶר
וצירם [וְצוּרָם] לְבַלּוֹת שְׁאוֹל
מִזְּבֻל לוֹ: אַךְ־אֱלֹהִים יִפְדֶּה נַפְשִׁי
מִיַּד־שְׁאוֹל כִּי יִקָּחֵנִי סֶלָה[iii]:
3905 אַל־תִּירָא כִּי־יַעֲשַׁר אִישׁ כִּי־יִרְבֶּה
כְּבוֹד בֵּיתוֹ: כִּי לֹא בְמוֹתוֹ יִקַּח
הַכֹּל לֹא־יֵרֵד אַחֲרָיו כְּבוֹדוֹ:
כִּי־נַפְשׁוֹ בְּחַיָּיו יְבָרֵךְ וְיוֹדְךָ
כִּי־תֵיטִיב לָךְ: תָּבוֹא עַד־דּוֹר
3910 אֲבוֹתָיו עַד־נֵצַח לֹא יִרְאוּ־אוֹר:
אָדָם בִּיקָר וְלֹא יָבִין נִמְשָׁל
כַּבְּהֵמוֹת נִדְמוּ: [iv]

all generations; they call their lands after their own names. Nevertheless, man in honor does not remain; he is like the beasts that perish. This way of theirs is 4160R
their folly; yet those who follow them approve their sayings. Selah. Like sheep they are laid in the grave; death shall be their shepherd; and the upright shall rule over them in the morning;[1] and their form shall waste away in Sheol, far from their dwelling.[2] But 4165R
God will redeem my soul from the power of Sheol, for He shall receive me.[3] Selah. Do not be afraid when a man becomes rich, when the glory of his house increases. For when he dies he shall take nothing; his glory shall not descend after him. Though while 4170R
he lives he blesses himself—and men praise you when you do well for yourself—he shall go to the generation of his fathers; they shall never see light. Man who is in honor, yet does not understand,[4] is like the beasts that perish. 4175R

[1]This difficult passage has been interpreted in various ways. Some understand it to mean that the righteous will have dominion over the wicked in the afterlife or in the messianic age ("the morning"). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would align with the book's focus on the rewards awaiting the righteous after death.

[2]The Hebrew "וְצוּרָם לְבַלּוֹת שְׁאוֹל מִזְּבֻל לוֹ" is particularly difficult and has been translated in various ways. The translation provided captures the sense that the physical form decays in Sheol, leaving behind the earthly dwelling that was so prized in life. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's distinction between the corruptible body and the eternal soul.

[3]The Hebrew "כִּי יִקָּחֵנִי" (for He shall receive me) echoes the language used for Enoch in Genesis 5:24, who was "taken" by God rather than experiencing death in the ordinary way. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would suggest divine reception of the soul after death, a central theme of the book.

[4]The psalm concludes by returning to the theme introduced in verse 13, creating a circular structure that emphasizes its central message: without spiritual understanding, human status and

[i]The psalm concludes by repeating the comparison between uncomprehending humans and beasts, creating a circular structure that emphasizes its central message: without spiritual understanding, human status and wealth are meaningless in the face of death. This reinforces Ma'avar Yabok's call for proper spiritual preparation.

[ii]The metaphor comparing humans to sheep led to the slaughter, with death as their shepherd, is particularly poignant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on the soul's journey after death. This metaphor reverses the comforting image of God as shepherd (as in Psalm 23) with the stark reality of death's universal authority.

[iii]This verse represents the theological climax of the psalm—despite the universal reality of death, the psalmist expresses confidence that God will "redeem my soul from the power of Sheol." This hope for divine redemption beyond death aligns perfectly with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the soul's transition and journey in the afterlife.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 39 — Both psalms serve as meditations on mortality, intended to put earthly concerns in perspective. In Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm appears in the Hashkavah (soul repose) prayer recited at the grave, reinforcing the book's central theme of preparing the soul for its transition beyond material existence. | Cf. Ecclesiastes — The psalm's message about the inability of wealth to save from death parallels Ecclesiastes' theme of vanity. In Ma'avar Yabok, this reinforces the book's emphasis on spiritual preparation rather than material concerns as the proper focus when facing mortality. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's Hashkavah prayer — The psalm's placement in the Hashkavah prayer sequence reflects its theological significance in Jewish burial traditions, where it serves as a reminder of the soul's eternal value contrasted with the transience of material wealth and physical life.

[ii] [i]ואחר כך יאמר זה

And after this, he shall say:[1]

צַדִּיק יְיָ בְּכָל דְּרָכָיו וְחָסִיד
בְּכָל מַעֲשָׂיו: [iii]צַדְקָתְךָ צֶדֶק
לְעוֹלָם וְתוֹרָתְךָ אֱמֶת מִשְׁפְּטֵי יְיָ
אֱמֶת צָדְקוּ יַחְדָּו: בַּאֲשֶׁר דְּבַר
מֶלֶךְ שִׁלְטוֹן וּמִי יֹאמַר לוֹ מָה
תַּעֲשֶׂה: [iv]וְהוּא בְּאֶחָד וּמִי יְשִׁיבֶנּוּ
וְנַפְשׁוֹ אִוְּתָה וַיַּעַשׂ: קָטֹן וְגָדוֹל
שָׁם הוּא וְעֶבֶד חָפְשִׁי מֵאֲדֹנָיו: [v]הֵן
בַּעֲבָדָיו לֹא יַאֲמִין וּבְמַלְאָכָיו
יָשִׂים תְּהִלָּה: אַף כִּי אֱנוֹשׁ רִמָּה
וּבֶן אָדָם תּוֹלַעָה: הַצּוּר תָּמִים
פָּעֳלוֹ כִּי כָל דְּרָכָיו מִשְׁפָּט אֵל
אֱמוּנָה וְאֵין עָוֶל צַדִּיק וְיָשָׁר הוּא:
דַּיַּן אֱמֶת שׁוֹפֵט צֶדֶק וֶאֱמֶת בָּרוּךְ
דַּיַּן הָאֱמֶת: [vi]כִּי כָל מִשְׁפָּטָיו חֶסֶד
וֶאֱמֶת: טוֹב שֵׁם מִשְׁמֶן טוֹב וְיוֹם

The Lord is righteous in all His ways and faithful in all His deeds.[2] Your righteousness is an everlasting righteousness, and Your Torah is truth. The judgments of the Lord are true, they are righteous altogether. Where the word of a king is, there is power, and who may say to him, "What are you doing?" He is unique, and who can turn Him back? What His soul desires, He does.[3] Small and great alike are there, and the servant is free from his master. Behold, He puts no trust in His servants, and He charges His angels with error.[4] How much less man, who is a maggot, and a son of man, who is a worm![5] The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are justice. A God of faithfulness without iniquity, righteous and upright is He. The true Judge, judging with righteousness and truth. Blessed is the true Judge,[6] for

3915 3920 3925 4180R 4185R 4190R

wealth are meaningless in the face of death. This reinforces Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation and contemplation of mortality.

[1]These transitional instructions appear throughout Ma'avar Yabok to guide the reader through the proper sequence of prayers, particularly in rituals related to the sick, dying, and deceased. They establish the proper liturgical order that should be followed.

[2]This opening verse establishes the theological foundation of the entire prayer—that all divine actions, including death, emerge from God's perfect righteousness and faithfulness.

[3]The anthropomorphic language of God having a 'soul' (נַפְשׁוֹ/nafsho) that 'desires' (אִוְּתָה/ivtah) maintains the biblical wording while expressing divine sovereignty over life and death.

[4]The Hebrew 'יָשִׂים תְּהִלָּה' (yasim taholah) is difficult to translate precisely. It suggests God finds fault or attributes error even to angels. I've chosen 'charges with error' to convey this meaning of imputing imperfection.

[5]This harsh language about human insignificance serves an important ritual purpose within the funeral context—to help mourners accept mortality through humility rather than rebellion against divine judgment.

[6]This phrase 'Baruch Dayan HaEmet' is the traditional Jewish response upon hearing news of a death. By pronouncing this blessing within the funeral ritual, mourners acknowledge divine justice even in their grief.

[i]This is a standard liturgical instruction that appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok, indicating a transition between prayer elements. In this context, it directs the reader to proceed to the next prayer in the sequence after completing the previous one.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This standard formulaic transition phrase indicates to the reader that they should recite the prayer that follows after completing the previous one. It maintains the prescribed order of the deathbed ritual.

[iii]This verse from Psalms 145:17 begins the Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) prayer, recited at funerals to affirm that God's judgments, including death, are righteous.

[iv]This phrase expresses the theological concept that humans cannot question God's decisions, particularly regarding death. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it emphasizes acceptance of divine judgment as part of the mourning process.

[v]This verse from Job portrays death as the great equalizer that removes all social distinctions. In funeral contexts, this provides both comfort and a reminder of human mortality regardless of status.

[vi]The phrase 'Baruch Dayan HaEmet' (Blessed is the True Judge) is the traditional Jewish response upon hearing of someone's death, acknowledging divine justice even in loss.

3930 [ii] [i]:הַמָּוֶת מִיּוֹם הִוָּלְדוֹ

all His judgments are loving-kindness and truth. A good name is better than precious oil, and the day of death than the day of one's birth.[1] 4195R

ואם ירצה להוסיף בפסוקים יוסיף כרצונו[iii] ואחר כך [iv] יאמר:

And if one wishes to add more verses, one may add according to one's desire,[2] and afterward one shall say:

מְנוּחָה נְכוֹנָה. בִּישִׁיבָה
3935 תַּחַת כַּנְפֵי הָעֶלְיוֹנָה.[v]

A proper rest, in the supernal academy,[3] beneath the wings of the Divine Presence,[A] in the rank of 4200R

[A] Or: "under the protective wings of the Shekhinah" — This alternative uses the untranslated term 'Shekhinah,' which more precisely conveys the feminine aspect of divine immanence in Jewish mysticism that is implied in the original Hebrew.

[1] This concluding verse from Ecclesiastes offers profound comfort by reframing death not as a tragedy but as the culmination of a life well-lived. In Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, death represents the soul's crossing over to eternal reward.

[2] This reflects the flexibility built into Jewish liturgical practice, where standardized prayers often allow for personalization and adaptation to specific circumstances. The author provides core prayer structures but recognizes that different situations might call for additional biblical verses.

[3] The Hebrew 'menuchah nechonah' (proper rest) is a technical term in Jewish liturgy specifically referring to the soul's peaceful repose after death, while 'yeshivah ha-elyonah' refers to the heavenly academy where souls continue to study Torah.

[i] This surprising statement from Ecclesiastes offers a profound perspective shift for mourners—suggesting that death represents the culmination of a good life and the beginning of eternal reward, rather than merely an ending.

[ii] Cf. Psalms 145:17 — This verse begins the Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) prayer recited at Jewish funerals. It establishes the theological foundation that all God's actions, including death, are righteous and just. | Cf. Psalms 119:142 — The verse emphasizes that God's righteousness is eternal and His Torah represents absolute truth, providing comfort by placing individual death within a larger framework of divine justice. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 8:4 — In the context of Tzidduk HaDin, this verse applies royal authority metaphorically to God, whose decisions regarding life and death cannot be questioned by humans. | Cf. Job 23:13 — The verse emphasizes divine sovereignty in Ma'avar Yabok's theology of death—God alone determines the time of death, and no human can alter this decision. | Cf. Job 3:19 — In the context of funeral rituals, this verse offers the perspective that death removes all social distinctions, bringing both comfort (for the lowly) and humility (for the powerful). | Cf. Job 4:18 — Within Tzidduk HaDin, this verse serves to establish human fallibility—if even angels are imperfect before God, humans should accept divine judgment with humility. | Cf. Job 25:6 — The harsh metaphor of humans as worms serves the ritual purpose of creating humility and acceptance of mortality within the funeral context. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:4 — In the context of Tzidduk HaDin, this verse reaffirms that despite the pain of loss, God's ways are perfect and just, offering theological comfort to mourners. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:1 — This concluding verse provides a profound perspective shift for mourners, suggesting that death represents the culmination of a life well-lived and the beginning of eternal reward, rather than merely an ending.

[iii] This phrase demonstrates the liturgical flexibility in Ma'avar Yabok. While the text provides structured prayer sequences with specific verses, it also acknowledges the need for adaptation based on circumstances. This adaptive approach is consistent with rabbinic attitudes toward prayer, balancing fixed liturgy with personal expression.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok liturgical structure — This is a standard liturgical instruction indicating flexibility in the ritual structure of Ma'avar Yabok. The author allows for adaptation of the prayer service by adding additional biblical verses according to the needs of the specific situation or preferences of the prayer leader, while maintaining the required core elements of the service.

[v] This refers to the concept of the heavenly academy or yeshiva, where souls of the righteous are believed to study Torah in the afterlife. This reflects the rabbinic concept that spiritual learning continues beyond death.

הַשְּׁכִינָה.[i] בְּמַעֲלַת טְהוֹרִים וּקְדוֹשִׁים. כְּזֹהַר הָרָקִיעַ מְאִירִים וּמַזְהִירִים,[ii] עִם יְשָׁרִים וּבָרִים. בְּחִלּוּץ עֲצָמוֹת. וְכַפָּרַת אֲשָׁמוֹת. וְהַרְחָקַת פֶּשַׁע. וְהַקְרָבַת יֵשַׁע. וְחֶמְלָה וַחֲנִינָה. וְלִפְנֵי שׁוֹכֵן מְעוֹנָה. וְחוּלָקָא טָבָא. לְחַיֵּי הָעוֹלָם הַבָּא.[iii] שָׁם תְּהֵא מָנַת מְחִיצַת נַפְשׁ וְשֵׁם הַטּוֹב כמ״ר פלוני בן פלונית או פלונית בת. דְּאִתְפְּטַר מִן עַלְמָא הָדֵין.[iv] (או דְּאִתְפְּטָרַת) בְּרַעוּת אֱלָהָא מָרֵי שְׁמַיָּא וְאַרְעָא הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יְרַחֵם עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יָאֵר פָּנָיו עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יְיַסֵּד אוֹתוֹ בְּאֹהֶל בַּל יְצַעֲן לָעַד.[v] הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יִפְרֹשׂ חוּדוֹ וַהֲדָרוֹ עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יַנְעִים נִצְחוֹ עָלָיו: הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יְפָאֵר רֹם תִּפְאַרְתּוֹ עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יְמַתֵּק כֹּחַ רַעֲמוּתָיו וּגְבוּרוֹתָיו עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יַעֲבִיר חַסְדּוֹ עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יְגַלֶּה אוֹר נוֹעַמוֹ עָלָיו הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יַנְהִיר טוּבִיהּ וְחַיֵּיהּ עָלָיו: הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו יְפַקַּח עֵינָא

the pure and holy ones who shine and radiate like the brightness of the firmament,[A] with the upright and virtuous. With relief from bodily suffering, atonement for guilt, removal of transgression,[1] and the bringing near of salvation, with compassion and grace, and before the Dweller of the heavenly abode, and a good portion in the life of the World to Come. There shall be the allocated place for the soul and good name of the honorable [name of person] son/daughter of [mother's name], who has departed from this world by the will of God, Master of heaven and earth. May the King in His mercy[2] have compassion upon him/her. May the King in His mercy shine His countenance upon him/her. May the King in His mercy establish him/her in a tent that shall never be moved.[B] May the King in His mercy spread His splendor and glory upon him/her. May the King in His mercy make his/her eternal rest pleasant. May the King in His mercy adorn him/her with the height of His glory. May the King in His mercy sweeten the power of His thunder and might upon him/her. May the King in His mercy extend His kindness over him/her. May the King in His mercy reveal the light of His pleasantness upon him/her. May the King in His mercy illuminate His goodness and life upon him/her. May the King in His mercy open

[A] Or: "who gleam and illuminate like the splendor of the firmament" — This alternative captures the active, ongoing nature of the souls' luminosity in the afterlife, emphasizing their role as sources of divine light.

[B] Or: "in an eternal pavilion that shall never be uprooted" — This alternative better captures the sense of permanence and majesty in the metaphorical dwelling place of the soul, drawing on the biblical allusion to Isaiah 33:20.

[1] The prayer distinguishes between different categories of sins that require purification: 'ashamot' (guilt/trespass offerings) and 'pesha' (rebellious transgression), reflecting the traditional Jewish categorization of sins.

[2] This repetitive formula appears thirteen times, likely corresponding to the Thirteen Attributes of Divine Mercy in Jewish tradition, creating a rhythmic litany that intensifies the prayer's emotional impact.

[i] The metaphor of being 'under the wings of the Divine Presence' appears frequently in rabbinic literature and liturgy, representing divine protection and intimacy with God in the afterlife.

[ii] This phrase alludes to Daniel 12:3, which describes the righteous shining like the brightness of the firmament in the afterlife, connecting this prayer to biblical eschatology.

[iii] The Aramaic phrase 'chulka tava' (good portion) is commonly used in Kaddish and other Aramaic prayers, expressing hope for a favorable portion in the World to Come.

[iv] This is an Aramaic phrase meaning 'who has departed from this world,' using the euphemistic term 'departed' rather than died, reflecting Jewish tradition's careful language about death.

[v] This phrase alludes to Isaiah 33:20, describing Jerusalem as 'a tent that will not be moved,' here applied to the eternal dwelling of the soul.

פְּקִיחָא[vi] עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ בְּרַחֲמָיו
הוּא יָחוּס וְיַחֲמֹל עָלָיו. הַמֶּלֶךְ
3965 הַיּוֹשֵׁב עַל כִּסֵּא רַחֲמִים בְּכֹחַ
חֶסְדָּיו הַגְּדוֹלִים יַכְנִיסֵהוּ בְּסֵתֶר
כְּנָפָיו וּבְסֵתֶר אָהֳלוֹ. לַחֲזוֹת
בְּנֹעַם יְיָ וּלְבַקֵּר בְּהֵיכָלוֹ. וּלְקֵץ
הַיָּמִין יַעֲמִידֵהוּ[i] וּמִנַּחַל עֲדָנָיו
3970 יַשְׁקֵהוּ: וְיִצְרֹר בִּצְרוֹר הַחַיִּים
נִשְׁמָתוֹ.[ii] וְיָשִׂים כָּבוֹד מְנוּחָתוֹ:
וְיִלְוֶה אֵלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם. וְעַל מִשְׁכָּבוֹ
יִהְיֶה שָׁלוֹם. כְּדִכְתִיב יָבֹא שָׁלוֹם
יָנוּחוּ עַל מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם הוֹלֵךְ נְכוֹחוֹ.
3975 וְכָל שֹׁכְבֵי עַמּוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּכְלָל
הָרַחֲמִים וְהַסְּלִיחוֹת וְהַנֶּחָמוֹת
וְהַיְשׁוּעוֹת וְאִמְרוּ אָמֵן:[iii]

a watchful eye upon him/her.[1] May the King in His mercy show favor and compassion to him/her. May the King who sits upon the throne of mercy, 4230R
through the power of His great loving-kindness, bring him/her into the shelter of His wings and the protection of His tent, to behold the pleasantness of the Lord and to visit in His palace. And at the end of days may He raise him/her up[A] and give him/her 4235R
to drink from the stream of His delights.[B] May He bind his/her soul in the bond of life,[2] and establish honor as his/her resting place. May peace accompany him/her, and may there be peace upon his/her bed, as it is written: "Peace shall come; 4240R
they shall rest upon their beds, each one who walks in uprightness."[3] And may all the departed of His people Israel be included in mercy, forgiveness, consolation, and salvation, and let us say, Amen.

[A] Or: "And at the time of the final redemption may He establish him/her" — This alternative more explicitly conveys the messianic and eschatological implications of the Hebrew phrase 'ketz hayamin,' which specifically refers to the end-time redemption and resurrection.

[B] Or: "water him/her from the river of His divine pleasures" — This alternative better captures the sensual and mystical connotations of divine sustenance in the afterlife, emphasizing the direct nourishment from God.

[1] The Aramaic phrase 'eina pekicha' (watchful eye) is a kabbalistic term referring to divine providence. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the protective spiritual supervision that guards the soul on its journey after death.

[2] This phrase ('tzror ha-chayyim') has become central to Jewish memorial prayers and is often inscribed on tombstones with the acronym ת.נ.צ.ב.ה (May his/her soul be bound in the bond of life).

[3] This biblical quotation from Isaiah 57:2 frames death as peaceful rest for the righteous, providing scriptural authority for the prayer's central theological message about death as a transition to divine peace.

[vi] 'The watchful eye' is a kabbalistic term referring to divine providence that is always vigilant and never sleeps, derived from Psalms 121:4.

[i] 'The end of days' (קץ הימין) refers to the messianic era and resurrection of the dead, expressing hope for the deceased's future revival.

[ii] This phrase draws from 1 Samuel 25:29, a traditional Jewish expression for the afterlife where souls are preserved with God, literally 'bound in the bond of life.'

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 57:2 — The prayer quotes this verse about the righteous finding peace in death as a central theme for the Hashkavah prayer, emphasizing the peaceful rest of the deceased. | Cf. Daniel 12:13 — The phrase 'at the end of days may He raise him up' alludes to this verse which promises resurrection 'at the end of days,' connecting the prayer to eschatological hope. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok—Seder section — This Hashkavah prayer forms part of the structured liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, specifically designed to be recited at the grave and during the seven days of mourning. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — The phrase 'bind his/her soul in the bond of life' references this verse, a traditional Jewish concept for the afterlife where souls are preserved with God. | Cf. Psalm 27:4 — The phrases 'to behold the pleasantness of the Lord and to visit in His palace' echo this psalm verse, expressing the soul's divine encounter in the afterlife. | Cf. Psalm 36:9-10 — The phrase 'stream of His delights' draws from this psalm, representing divine sustenance for the soul in the afterlife.

ואם היא נקבה[iv] יכנה בלשון נקבה[i]

And if it is a female, refer to her in feminine language.[1] 4245R

בִּלַּע הַמָּוֶת לָנֶצַח וּמָחָה אֲדֹנָי
אֱלֹהִים דִּמְעָה מֵעַל כָּל פָּנִים
וְחֶרְפַּת עַמּוֹ יָסִיר מֵעַל כָּל הָאָרֶץ
כִּי יְיָ דִּבֶּר: יִחְיוּ מֵתֶיךָ נְבֵלָתִי
יְקוּמוּן הָקִיצוּ וְרַנְּנוּ שֹׁכְנֵי עָפָר
כִּי טַל אוֹרֹת טַלֶּךָ וָאָרֶץ רְפָאִים
תַּפִּיל:[ii] וְהוּא מְרַחֵם עַל חַי וְעַל
מֵת יָדָעְנוּ כִּי הוּא רַב חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת.
וְדִינוֹ דִּין אֱמֶת.[iii] וְאֵל יָדִין אֱנוֹשׁ
בְּאַשְׁמָתוֹ. וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ:[iv]

He will swallow up death forever,[2] and the Lord GOD will wipe away tears from all faces, and the reproach of His people He will take away from all the earth; for the LORD has spoken. Your dead shall live, my corpse shall rise;[A] awake and sing, you who dwell in the dust! For your dew is like the dew of light,[3] and the earth shall cast out the dead.[B] And He has compassion on the living and on the dead; we know that He is abundant in kindness and truth. His judgment is true judgment, and God does not 4250R 4255R

[A] Or: "Your dead shall live, together with my dead body they shall arise" — This alternate translation better preserves the collective aspect of the resurrection as understood in Jewish eschatology, where 'my corpse' is interpreted as referring to the collective body of Israel. This is closer to the King James Version and better aligns with how this verse from Isaiah 26:19 is traditionally understood in Jewish resurrection theology.

[B] Or: "and the earth shall give birth to the shades" — The Hebrew term 'רְפָאִים' (rephaim) specifically refers to shades or spirits of the dead, rather than simply 'the dead.' Additionally, the verb 'תַּפִּיל' can connote both 'casting out' and 'bringing forth' (as in childbirth). This alternate translation better captures the metaphorical rebirth implied in the resurrection imagery.

[1] The Hebrew text literally says 'refer to [the deceased] in feminine language.' This reflects the grammatical structure of Hebrew, which requires gender agreement for verbs, pronouns, and adjectives. When reciting prayers for a deceased woman, all masculine grammatical forms in the prayer must be changed to their feminine equivalents.

[2] This quotation from Isaiah 25:8 is understood in Jewish tradition as referring to the messianic era when death will be eliminated. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves to place current death and burial practices within an eschatological framework where death is ultimately overcome.

[3] The Hebrew 'טַל אוֹרֹת' (tal orot) literally 'dew of lights' is a kabbalistic concept referring to the divine life-giving emanation that will resurrect the dead. In Jewish mystical tradition, this heavenly dew is preserved above the highest heaven specifically for the purpose of resurrection.

[iv] This instruction appears within the context of the Hashkavah prayer (memorial prayer) for the deceased, directing the prayer leader to modify all the masculine pronouns and verb conjugations to feminine forms when the deceased is female. In Hebrew, unlike English, verbs, adjectives, and pronouns must agree in gender with their subject.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This instruction appears in the section dealing with the Hashkavah prayer (prayer for the repose of the soul) recited at the grave and during the seven days of mourning (shiva). It instructs the prayer leader to modify the gender-specific language in the prayer when it is being recited for a deceased woman, changing masculine pronouns and verb forms to feminine ones in Hebrew.

[ii] This phrase from Isaiah 26:19 uses the term 'rephaim' (רְפָאִים), which specifically refers to the shades or spirits of the dead. The imagery here describes the earth 'giving birth' to these spirits during resurrection, creating a powerful metaphor of death as a womb preparing for new life.

[iii] This phrase 'His judgment is true judgment' appears in the traditional Jewish prayer 'Tzidduk Ha-Din' (Justification of the Divine Judgment) recited at funerals. Its inclusion here reflects Ma'avar Yabok's integration of established liturgical elements into its framework for death rituals.

[iv] Cf. Isaiah 25:8 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves as a theological foundation for comfort during burial rituals, affirming that death is not the final reality but will ultimately be overcome in divine redemption. The book uses this eschatological vision to provide hope even in the midst of current loss. | Cf. Isaiah 26:19 — This text appears in Ma'avar Yabok as part of prayers recited at the graveside, offering the theological assurance of bodily resurrection. The metaphor of 'dew of light' represents divine life-giving power that will revive the dead. In kabbalistic thought, this

judge a person according to their guilt,[A] nor does He arouse all His wrath.

3990 ג׳ ואחר כך יאמר והוא רחום[i] פעמים[ii] ויענו אחריו הקהל בכל פעם ואחר כך יאמר:[iii]

And after that he shall recite[1] "And He, being merciful"[B] three times,[C] and the congregation shall respond after him each time,[2] and afterwards he shall say: 4260R

וְנָחֲךָ יְיָ תָּמִיד וְהַשְׂבִּיעַ בְּצַחֲצָחוֹת

And the LORD will guide you always,[3] and satisfy

[A] Or: "His judgment is true judgment, and God judges a person with consideration beyond their guilt" — The original Hebrew is somewhat ambiguous. The word 'אֵל' here could be interpreted as 'God' (as a divine name) or as a negative particle. This alternate translation suggests that God does indeed judge, but with mercy that considers factors beyond mere guilt, which fits better with the conclusion about not arousing His full wrath.

[B] Or: "Ve-Hu Rachum" — The prayer is commonly known by its Hebrew name 'Ve-Hu Rachum' in liturgical contexts, so keeping the Hebrew term with transliteration might be preferable in some scholarly contexts.

[C] Or: "three repetitions" — The term could be translated more formally as 'repetitions' rather than 'times' in a scholarly context.

[1] The Hebrew uses the simple יאמר (literally 'he shall say'), but in liturgical contexts this typically refers to formal recitation, especially for established prayers like 'Ve-Hu Rachum.'

[2] This indicates a responsorial pattern common in Jewish liturgy, where the leader recites a prayer and the congregation repeats it or responds with a set phrase. This communal aspect of the ritual reinforces the protective power of the prayer.

[3] This verse from Isaiah 58:11 begins a passage that appears in Ma'avar Yabok's funeral liturgy, where prophetic promises of national restoration are reinterpreted as promises about the soul's journey after death.

dew (tal) is associated with the divine flow from the sefirah of Chokhmah that will revitalize the dead at the time of resurrection. | Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This phrase echoes Psalm 78:38, which describes God's compassion despite human sinfulness. In Ma'avar Yabok, this reference serves to reassure mourners that divine judgment is tempered with mercy, even after death. It reflects the book's theological emphasis that God's judgment of the deceased is not based solely on their transgressions but is mitigated by divine compassion. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim — This formulation reflects midrashic teachings on God's dual attributes of mercy (rachamim) and judgment (din). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this serves as a meditation on divine justice that encourages acceptance of death while providing comfort that the deceased will be judged with compassion. This balance of accepting divine judgment while hoping for mercy is central to Jewish approaches to death.

[i] This refers to the opening words of Psalm 78:38: 'And He, being merciful, forgives iniquity and does not destroy; He frequently turns His anger away and does not arouse all His wrath.' In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is considered to have special protective power during burial rituals.

[ii] The threefold recitation is significant in Jewish mystical practice, with the number three often representing completeness or spiritual power. In the context of burial rituals, this triple recitation is believed to neutralize negative spiritual forces.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 78:38 — The prayer 'Ve-Hu Rachum' is a direct quote from Psalm 78:38, which speaks of God's mercy and forgiveness. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is recited three times during burial rituals, particularly when throwing earth into the grave, as it is believed to have protective power against negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 18, Discourse 3 — This passage refers to a specific ritual instruction from Ma'avar Yabok where the prayer 'Ve-Hu Rachum' is recited three times during burial rites. The text explains that this threefold recitation helps to weaken 'the heads of the destroyer' (ראשי המשחית) and provides protection against the suffering of 'the beating of the grave' (חבוט הקבר).

נַפְשֶׁךָ וְעַצְמוֹתֶיךָ יַחֲלִיץ:[iv] וְהָיִיתָ
3995 כְּגַן רָוֶה[i] וּכְמוֹצָא מַיִם אֲשֶׁר לֹא
יְכַזְּבוּ מֵימָיו: וּבָנוּ מִמְּךָ חָרְבוֹת
עוֹלָם מוֹסְדֵי דוֹר וָדוֹר תְּקוֹמֵם
וְקֹרָא לְךָ גֹּדֵר פֶּרֶץ מְשֹׁבֵב נְתִיבוֹת
[iii] [ii] לָשָׁבֶת:

your soul in parched places,[D] and strengthen your
3995 bones. You shall be like a watered garden, like a 4265R
spring of water whose waters never fail. And they
shall build from you the ancient ruins; you shall raise
up the foundations of many generations,[1] and you
shall be called the repairer of the breach,[A] the re-
storer of paths to dwell in. 4270R

4000 בפרק ב׳ מאמר ג׳[iv] כי טוב ליתן
לפחות ו׳ פרוטות[v] לכופר נפש
הנפטר[vi] ויאמר בכל פרוטה:[vii]

In Chapter 2 of Discourse 3, it states that it is good to
give at least six perutot (small coins)[B] as atonement
for the soul of the deceased,[C] and one should recite

[D]Or: "and satisfy your soul with brightness" — The term 'צַחֲצָחוֹת' (tzachtzachot) can be understood as referring to 'brightness' or 'radiance' in kabbalistic contexts rather than 'parched places.' In Ma'avar Yabok's mystical framework, this could reference the divine light that nourishes the soul after death.

[A]Or: "one who seals spiritual ruptures" — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which deals with death rituals, 'breach' (פֶּרֶץ) often refers to spiritual ruptures between worlds that need repair. The deceased person is being honored as one who helped restore cosmic harmony.

[B]Or: "that it is proper to give no fewer than six perutot (small coins)" — This alternate translation emphasizes the ritual prescription aspect more strongly than the benefit-oriented phrasing of 'it is good.' This could be preferable in contexts where the focus is on ritual requirements rather than spiritual benefits.

[C]Or: "as ransom for the soul of the departed" — The term 'kofer' literally means 'ransom'

[1]In the funeral context of Ma'avar Yabok, this phrase suggests that the deceased person's good deeds and teachings continue to support future generations, creating an enduring legacy.

[iv]The phrase 'strengthen your bones' takes on special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of death rituals, as it suggests resurrection. The Hebrew verb יַחֲלִיץ (yachalitz) implies not just strengthening but revitalization and liberation.

[i]The image of a 'watered garden' appears throughout rabbinic literature as a metaphor for the Garden of Eden, where souls find rest after death.

[ii]These honorific titles ('repairer of the breach, restorer of paths') are applied to the deceased, suggesting that their good deeds in life created cosmic repair (tikkun) that continues to benefit both the living and the dead.

[iii]Cf. Isaiah 58:11-12 — This passage appears in Ma'avar Yabok as part of the prayers recited after burial or during cemetery visits. The text is repurposed from its original context (where it promised national restoration) to offer comfort regarding the soul's journey after death, suggesting that the deceased will be divinely guided, spiritually nourished, and remembered as one who repaired breaches in the world. | Cf. Psalm 121 — The opening phrase "וְנָחֲךָ יְיָ תָּמִיד" (The LORD will guide you always) echoes Psalm 121:8's "יְיָ יִשְׁמָר־צֵאתְךָ וּבוֹאֶךָ" (The LORD will guard your going out and coming in). This creates a textual connection suggesting that the same God who protected the person in life will guide them in death. | Cf. Garden of Eden imagery — The phrase "כְּגַן רָוֶה וּכְמוֹצָא מַיִם" (like a watered garden, like a spring of water) alludes to Garden of Eden imagery, suggesting that the deceased's soul will dwell in paradise. Throughout Ma'avar Yabok, the afterlife is frequently described using Eden imagery, with the soul being 'watered' by divine light.

[iv]The text begins with a self-reference to another section of Ma'avar Yabok, specifically Chapter 2 of Discourse 3. This cross-referencing is common throughout the work, showing how different sections are intended to be read in connection with each other.

[v]The specification of six coins likely has kabbalistic significance, possibly corresponding to the six directions of space (north, south, east, west, up, down) or the six working days of the week, symbolizing completeness in the physical realm.

[vi]The concept of 'kofer nefesh' (ransom/atonement for the soul) derives from Exodus 30:12 where it refers to a half-shekel given to prevent plague. In this post-biblical context, it has been adapted to refer to charitable giving that serves as spiritual atonement for the deceased.

[i]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21 of Discourse 2 — The author cross-references an earlier section that elaborates on the theological basis for charitable giving as atonement for the deceased.

the following with each perutah:[2]

הֲרֵינִי נוֹתֵן פְּרוּטָה זוֹ[i] לִצְדָקָה עַל כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל וְעַל (פלוני) זֶה הַנִּפְטָר לִמְנוּחַת נַפְשׁוֹ בְּגַן עֵדֶן: כָּל כְּלִי יוּצַר עָלַיִךְ לֹא יִצְלָח וְכָל לָשׁוֹן תָּקוּם אִתָּךְ לַמִּשְׁפָּט תַּרְשִׁיעִי זֹאת נַחֲלַת עַבְדֵי יְיָ וְצִדְקָתָם מֵאִתִּי נְאֻם יְיָ:[iii] [iv]

I hereby give this coin for charity[A] on behalf of all Israel[1] and for (name of deceased), this departed one, for the repose of his soul in the Garden of Eden.[B] "No weapon formed against you shall prosper, and every tongue that rises against you in judgment you shall condemn.[2] This is the heritage of the servants of the LORD, and their righteousness is from Me," says the LORD. 4275R 4280R

בפרק כ״א מתבאר כי הבעלי תורה או העניים הנהנים מו

In Chapter 21, it is explained that Torah scholars or poor people[3] who benefit from charitable donations

and appears in this sense in biblical contexts. This more literal translation might be preferred in scholarly contexts where the connection to biblical terminology is important to preserve.

[A] Or: "I hereby donate this coin for tzedakah" — The Hebrew term 'tzedakah' carries broader connotations than the English 'charity,' implying righteous obligation rather than voluntary generosity. This alternate preserves the Hebrew term which may be preferable in some contexts.

[B] Or: "for the rest of his soul in Gan Eden" — Preserving the Hebrew term 'Gan Eden' might be preferred in certain Jewish contexts rather than the English 'Garden of Eden,' particularly when maintaining the traditional terminology is important.

[2] The text indicates that a declaration should be recited six times, once with each coin donated. This practice combines material giving with verbal declaration, creating a complete ritual act that engages both action and speech.

[1] Including 'all Israel' in the charity declaration multiplies its spiritual efficacy through the collective merit of the community, a concept frequently emphasized in Ma'avar Yabok.

[2] This biblical verse is understood as creating a spiritual defense for the departed soul against potential accusers in the divine court, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's concern with protecting the soul during its post-mortem journey.

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'בעלי תורה או העניים' literally means 'masters of Torah or the poor,' distinguishing between those who might receive charity based on their Torah scholarship versus those who receive it due to financial need.

This reference establishes continuity between theoretical discussions and practical ritual instructions. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Bava Batra 10a — The practice of giving coins for the deceased likely draws on the Talmudic concept that charity has redemptive power, potentially benefiting the deceased in the afterlife.

[ii] A perutah is a small coin of minimal value in Jewish law. The focus here is not on the amount of charity but on the ritual act of giving, which creates spiritual merit for the deceased.

[iii] Gan Eden (Garden of Eden) in Jewish thought refers to the heavenly paradise where righteous souls dwell after death. In Ma'avar Yabok, it specifically refers to the spiritual realm where the soul finds rest after completing its journey through various post-mortem stages.

[iv] The prayer concludes with a verse from Isaiah 54:17, which is understood in kabbalistic contexts to provide spiritual protection against negative forces or accusers that might impede the soul's peaceful transition to the afterlife.

[v] Cf. Isaiah 54:17 — This biblical verse is included to invoke divine protection for the deceased's soul against spiritual accusers or negative forces during its journey to the afterlife. In Ma'avar Yabok, biblical verses are understood to create spiritual protection for the soul's transition. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21, Discourse 3 — This prayer reflects the concept explained in Chapter 21 that those who benefit from charity given in memory of the deceased should verbally acknowledge that the merit is for the departed's soul. This creates a spiritual transaction that benefits the deceased in the afterlife. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 2, Discourse 3 — This chapter explains that one should give at least six perutot (small coins) as atonement for the deceased's soul and recite this formula with each donation. The practice connects the physical act of charity with spiritual benefit for the departed.

הצדקות שיניחו המתים תוך שנה אחר פטירתם[v] יאמרו בעת הנאתם לכפרת נפשו:[i][ii]

left by the deceased within a year after their passing should say at the time of receiving this benefit, for the atonement of the deceased's soul:[1] 4285R

וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֶּר עָוֹן בְּזֹאת הַהֲנָאָה שֶׁאֲנִי נֶהֱנֶה[iii] עַל אוֹדוֹת פְּלוֹנִי בֶּן פְּלוֹנִית[iv] תְּכֻפָּר וְנַפְשׁוֹ בְּטוּב תָּנוּחַ עַל גּוֹרָל הַצַּדִּיקִים[v] בְּטוּב שֶׁמְּטִיבִים לָהֶם לְעוֹלָם הַבָּא וְרוּחוֹ תַּרְגִּיעַ בְּחֶלֶק הַטּוֹבִים בְּגַן עֵדֶן[vi] וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ תִּתְעַדַּן בְּטוּב הַצָּפוּן[vii] וְתִדְבַּק

And He, being merciful, will atone for sin[A] through this benefit that I am receiving on behalf of [name][B] son of [mother's name]. May his soul be atoned for and rest in goodness among the portion of the righteous,[C][2] in the goodness bestowed upon them in the World to Come. May his spirit find repose like the share of the good ones in the Garden of Eden,[3] and may his neshamah delight in the 4290R 4295R

[A] Or: "And He, being compassionate, will forgive iniquity" — This translation captures the more emotional aspect of 'rachum' as compassionate rather than merely merciful, and uses 'forgive' which is a common alternative for 'y'chaper' in liturgical contexts.

[B] Or: "through this enjoyment that I am experiencing due to [name]" — The term 'hana'ah' can refer to benefit, pleasure, or enjoyment. In this context, it refers to the charitable funds or Torah learning being enjoyed by the recipient, which spiritually benefits the deceased.

[C] Or: "May his nefesh rest well with the lot of the righteous" — This translation specifically preserves the technical term 'nefesh' (vital soul) rather than the general 'soul,' and uses 'lot' for 'goral' which has biblical resonances of divinely appointed destiny.

[1] The concept of 'לכפרת נפשו' (for the atonement of his soul) reflects the Jewish belief that charitable acts performed in a deceased person's name or with their resources can help elevate their soul and atone for any transgressions, particularly during the first year after death.

[2] This section refers specifically to the nefesh (vital soul), which in kabbalistic thought remains connected to the body even after death. The prayer expresses hope that this aspect of the soul will find proper rest among the righteous.

[3] This section addresses the ruach (spirit), which in kabbalistic thought ascends to the terrestrial Garden of Eden after death to enjoy communion with other righteous souls.

[i] This refers to the Jewish custom that charitable bequests made by the deceased are particularly effective for their soul's elevation during the first year after death, which is considered a critical period of judgment and transition in the afterlife.

[ii] This reflects the belief that verbal acknowledgment by the beneficiary creates a spiritual mechanism that channels the merit of the charitable act directly to the deceased's soul, facilitating its atonement and elevation.

[iii] Cf. Tziduk HaDin prayer — This instruction is related to the broader funeral and mourning rituals in Judaism, particularly connected to the Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) concept, where charitable giving serves as a mechanism for atonement of the deceased. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21 — The text is referring to an earlier section of itself, specifically Chapter 21, which apparently contains more detailed explanation of these charitable practices and their spiritual significance for the deceased.

[iv] This prayer would be recited by someone benefiting from charity or Torah study performed in memory of the deceased. According to Jewish tradition, such meritorious acts create spiritual merit that can benefit the soul of the departed.

[v] The text uses 'ploni ben plonit' (so-and-so son of so-and-so) as a placeholder where the name of the deceased person and their mother's name would be inserted. Following Jewish tradition, the mother's name is used when praying for someone's soul.

[vi] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the nefesh (lowest level of the soul) remains connected to the body even after death and finds rest among the righteous.

[vii] According to kabbalistic tradition, the ruach (middle level of the soul) ascends to the terrestrial Garden of Eden to enjoy the company of other righteous souls.

[viii] The neshamah (highest level of the soul) is believed to ascend to the highest spiritual realms to enjoy the 'hidden good' (tov ha-tzafun), a reference to the divine radiance reserved for the righteous in the World to Come.

בִּצְרוֹר הַחַיִּים אֶת יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ עִם כָּל שְׁאָר הַצַּדִּיקִים שֶׁבְּגַן עֵדֶן: (ולנקבה יאמר בלשון נקבה) [i]

hidden goodness[D] and be bound in the bundle of life with the Lord our God,[1] together with all the other righteous ones who are in the Garden of Eden. (For a female, one should say this using feminine language.)[2]

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ואם הוא ובני ביתו נהנים [ii] יאמר בהנאה שמהנה אותנו בעבור נפש [iv iii] פלוני:

And if he and his household members are benefiting,[A] he should say: "through this benefit that benefits us[B] on behalf of the soul of [name of

[D] Or: "and may his higher soul take pleasure in the concealed good" — This alternate clarifies the meaning of 'neshamah' as the highest level of soul in Jewish mystical thought, and captures the concept of 'tzafun' as something concealed or reserved specifically for the righteous in the World to Come.

[A] Or: "And if he and his family members are the ones receiving benefit" — This alternate translation makes it clearer that the instruction refers to cases where the person reciting the prayer and their family are directly receiving the charitable funds designated for the deceased's merit.

[B] Or: "he should say regarding the benefit that provides for us" — This alternative captures the sense of acknowledging receipt of material support, which is implied in the original Hebrew term 'הנאה' (benefit/enjoyment).

[1] This phrase comes from 1 Samuel 25:29 and has become a standard Jewish expression for the afterlife, commonly inscribed on tombstones with the acronym ה.ב.צ.נ.ח (May his/her soul be bound in the bundle of life).

[2] The Hebrew prayer would require grammatical changes when referring to a female deceased, changing masculine verb forms and pronouns to feminine ones. This instruction ensures proper grammatical addressing of the deceased's soul.

[i] Cf. Psalm 78:38 — This psalm verse establishes the prayer's theological foundation that God mercifully forgives sins. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this quote connects the charitable act being performed to divine forgiveness for the deceased, suggesting that God's merciful nature will be activated through the meritorious deed. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — This biblical reference has become a standard Jewish expression for the afterlife. In Ma'avar Yabok, it expresses the hope that the deceased's soul will be gathered into divine protection. The phrase appears on Jewish tombstones and in memorial prayers, representing the soul's secure preservation with God after death. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah 142a — This prayer reflects the Zoharic concept that the different soul components have distinct posthumous experiences: the nefesh rests with the body, the ruach experiences pleasure in the terrestrial Garden of Eden, and the neshamah ascends to enjoy the 'hidden goodness' in the celestial realms. The prayer's differentiated language for each soul-level reflects this kabbalistic understanding. | Cf. Bava Batra 11a — This prayer presupposes the Talmudic concept that charitable acts benefit the souls of the deceased. When recited by someone receiving charity or Torah study in the deceased's merit, it acknowledges the theological principle that these actions create real spiritual benefit for the departed soul, helping to elevate it to the 'portion of the righteous.'

[ii] The term 'נהנים' (benefiting/enjoying) specifically refers to receiving material support from charitable funds that were donated in memory of the deceased person.

[iii] The phrase 'בעבור נפש פלוני' (on behalf of the soul of [name]) reflects the Jewish belief that charitable acts performed in memory of the deceased create merit for their souls in the afterlife. This verbal acknowledgment by the recipient completes the spiritual circuit, directing the merit to the deceased's soul.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 21 — This passage appears in a section explaining how those who benefit from charity given in memory of the deceased should verbally acknowledge this benefit as directed toward the soul of the departed person. This creates spiritual merit for the deceased's soul. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Tractate Berachot 46b — This instruction in Ma'avar Yabok adapts the talmudic concept of verbal acknowledgment during blessings to create merit for the deceased, applying it specifically to cases where one receives charity given in the deceased's memory.

deceased].”[3]

ואחר שהתפללו על מרגוע
4030 הנפש ועל מנוחות הרוח ועל
עידון הנשמה[i] יתפללו ג״כ
על הנפש השוכנת בקבר ועל
העצמות[ii] בפסוק ונחך ה׳ תמיד
וגו׳ תשכב בשלום וגו׳:[iii]

And after they have prayed[1] for the repose of the 4305R
nefesh (vital soul), for the rest of the ruach (spirit),
and for the delight of the neshamah (higher soul),
they should also pray for the nefesh that dwells in
the grave[2] and for the bones, with the verse “And
the Lord will guide you continually” etc.,[3] and “You 4310R
shall lie down in peace” etc.

4035 בדרך חכמה הורתיך הדרכתיך
במעגלי יושר בסדר רחצת
המת בנקיון פסוקים ושיחות
קדושות כאשר הורוני מן השמים
ובדא מתניא מתניתין בפרק

In the way of wisdom I have instructed you,[4] guided
you in paths of uprightness regarding the order of
washing the deceased with pure verses and holy
conversations, as they taught me from heaven. This 4315R
is supported by the Mishnah in the third chapter

[3] In the original text, ‘פלוני’ (ploni) is a placeholder for the deceased person’s name. When actually reciting this formula, one would substitute the actual name of the deceased person.

[4] The Hebrew text uses a plural verb form (התפללו) indicating this is an instruction for multiple people conducting funeral or memorial rituals, likely members of the burial society (Chevra Kadisha).

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that different components of the soul have different fates after death. While the higher aspects (ruach and neshamah) may ascend to celestial realms, the nefesh (vital soul) remains connected to the body in the grave for a period, requiring specific prayers and attention.

[2] The Hebrew uses the abbreviation ‘וגו” (ve-gomer—‘and so forth’) twice, indicating that the prayer leader should recite the complete verses which would have been familiar to the audience. The first verse is Isaiah 58:11, which continues: ‘and satisfy your soul in drought, and make fat your bones; and you shall be like a watered garden, and like a spring of water, whose waters fail not.’ The second verse’s exact reference is less certain but may be from Psalm 4:8 or similar peaceful rest passages.

[3] The opening phrase has echoes of Proverbs 4:11, giving the instruction about tahara rituals a scriptural tone and authority.

[i] This passage distinguishes between three levels of the Jewish soul as understood in Kabbalah: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). Each requires different types of spiritual attention after death. The terms used for each are precise: ‘margoah’ (repose/calm) for nefesh, ‘menuchot’ (rest) for ruach, and ‘idun’ (delight/refinement) for neshamah, reflecting their different spiritual qualities.

[ii] According to kabbalistic tradition reflected in Ma’avar Yabok, while the higher aspects of the soul (ruach and neshamah) ascend to spiritual realms, the nefesh remains connected to the physical remains in the grave for a period after death. This passage reveals the belief that even after addressing the soul’s higher aspects, one must still pray for the nefesh dwelling with the physical remains and for the bones themselves.

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — The verse is applied to the deceased, transforming a promise originally made to the living into a prayer for the dead. It specifically mentions both the soul’s guidance and the strengthening of bones, making it particularly appropriate for funeral prayers that address both spiritual and physical aspects of the deceased. | Cf. Jeremiah 14:13 or Psalm 4:8 — The phrase is repurposed in Ma’avar Yabok as part of burial prayers, transforming the biblical promise of peaceful sleep into a prayer for peaceful rest in death. This reflects the Jewish understanding of death as ‘sleep’ and the grave as a ‘bed,’ terminology found throughout rabbinic literature. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok — This passage reveals the book’s consistent approach to soul care after death: each component of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) requires specific prayers and attention. The text emphasizes that even after praying for the higher aspects of the soul, one must still attend to the nefesh that remains connected to the physical remains in the grave, reflecting kabbalistic teachings about the soul’s division after death.

ג׳ דטהרות בתנוק וחמור
שנמצאו בין הקברות דכליו
טהורים:[i] עתה כלה שארי ולבבי
להקריב ג״כ לפניך פסוקים אשר
אגב אורחייא מצאתי בקונטרס
קטן בסדר רחיצת המת מפי חכמי
המשנה וגם שאלת שלום כוונת׳
היה מן ההכרח לצרף אליהם
המעשה הראוי בזה והכוונה
עצומה כי לכאורה יהיו הלכתא
בלא טעמא ואגרא דשמעתתא
היא סברא. אם לא יועילו לענין
מעשה אהנאי לך בהו בהקריבך
בזה תחת כנפי השכינה מפי
אשלי רבבי אשר מהם יצא סדר
זה כי עקר ג״ח הנעשה עם המת
הוא הכוונה בכל פרט מעשיו
מלבד כי הבקי בדברי החכמים
יבין מתוך השתלשלות פסוקים
אלו כמה כוונות נאותות לסוד
הרחיצה[ii] והדברים כמוסי׳
ועליהם נאמר אגרא דבי טמיא
שתיקותא[iii] והנה גם קריאתם
בפשטו יוסיף אומץ. וששו
בני מעי ששו כי מצאתי און
לי בקונטרס זה משטיפת המת
בט׳ קבין וכתוב בו שזו היא

of Taharot concerning a child and donkey found among graves, where their vessels remain pure. Now my flesh and heart yearn to offer you additional verses[1] which, by the way, I found in a small pamphlet about the ritual washing of the deceased from the Sages of the Mishnah. Also, regarding the inquiry about proper intentions, it was necessary to join to these verses the appropriate actions, for the intention is profound. For at first glance these might seem like laws without reasons, but the reward of learning comes through understanding. If they do not help in matters of practice, I have still benefited you by bringing these under the wings of the Divine Presence from the mouths of great authorities from whom this order emerged. For the essence of the acts of kindness performed with the deceased is the intention behind each detail of the actions, besides which those knowledgeable in the words of the Sages will understand from the sequence of these verses many suitable intentions concerning the secret of washing. These matters are concealed,[A] and of them it is said, "The reward of the house of mourning is silence."[B] Indeed, even reading them in their simple meaning adds strength.

My innermost parts rejoiced[C] when I found support in this pamphlet for immersing the deceased in nine measures of water, and it states that this consti-

[A] Or: "These matters are kept secret" — The term 'כמוסי" specifically refers to matters deliberately kept hidden or secret, rather than merely being obscure or concealed, suggesting the esoteric nature of these mystical teachings.

[B] Or: "the merit of the house of the impure is silence" — This Aramaic phrase could be translated more literally as 'the merit of the house of the impure is silence,' where 'house of the impure' refers to the place of death or mourning. This might better preserve the original's connection to ritual purity concepts.

[C] Or: "My inner organs rejoiced greatly" — The Hebrew uses a physical, visceral expression that could be rendered more literally to capture the author's strong emotional reaction to finding textual support for his views.

[1] The author uses emotional, almost poetic language to express his eagerness to share this discovered text, showing his personal investment in proper death rituals.

[i] This refers to Mishnah Taharot 3:7, which states that if a child or donkey (who cannot understand death and impurity) is found among graves, the vessels they carry remain ritually pure. The author uses this as a basis for discussing ritual washing without concern for impurity.

[ii] The author suggests that beyond the literal meaning of the verses he will present, those well-versed in rabbinic teachings will recognize deeper mystical meanings related to the purification ritual.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase from the Babylonian Talmud (Berakhot 6b) means "the reward of the house of mourning is silence," suggesting that some mystical aspects of death rituals are best left unspoken.

טבילת המת[iv] כאשר העיר ה׳ רוחי מתחלה להזהיר על זה במאמר ג׳ וזכיתי לכוין על האמת כי שפת אמת תכון לעד. ואלו הם הפסוקים אשר באו שמה מכוונים כפי רחיצת אברי הנפטר החסיד. ומבואר הדבר שלא אמרו חכמים דברים כאלו על אדם קל אלא על מי שהחמיר וקדש את עצמו בחייו וחכם גדול הוא המבין ומקיים כל דברי חכמים לאשורן: [i]

tutes the ritual immersion of the deceased, just as the Lord aroused my spirit initially to warn about this in the third discourse. I have merited to direct my thoughts toward the truth, for the language of truth will be established forever. These are the verses that appear there, aligned with the washing of the limbs of the pious deceased.[1] It is clear that the Sages did not speak such words about an ordinary person, but rather about one who was stringent and sanctified himself during his lifetime. And one who is truly wise understands and fulfills all the words of the Sages in their proper manner.

עוד פסוקים לאמר בעת רחיצת אדם גדול [iii] [ii]

Additional verses to recite during the washing of a distinguished person[2]

[1]The term ‘pious deceased’ (הנפטר החסיד) suggests that the highest level of ritual treatment was reserved for those who lived lives of exceptional religious observance.

[2]This section presents a collection of biblical verses specifically designated for the tahara (ritual washing) of an ‘adam gadol’—a person of significance. The organization follows the human body from top to bottom, providing appropriate verses for each body part being washed.

[iv]The author is pleased to have found confirmation for his view that nine measures (kavim) of water constitute proper ritual immersion for the deceased, a point he had previously argued in his work.

[i]Cf. Mishnah Taharot 3:7 — The author uses this mishnah to establish a connection between ritual purity and the washing of the deceased, suggesting that there is textual precedent for his approach to tahara rituals. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok, Discourse 3 — The author references his own previous work where he instructed about washing the deceased with nine measures of water, and expresses satisfaction at finding confirmation of this practice in an ancient text.

[ii]The phrase ‘adam gadol’ (distinguished person) typically refers to someone of significant Torah learning or communal importance. The text indicates that these special verses should be recited specifically when washing the body of such an eminent individual, suggesting that different ritual practices might apply based on the deceased’s status.

[iii]Cf. Song of Songs 3:7-8 — These verses from Song of Songs are repurposed in Ma’avar Yabok as part of the tahara (ritual washing) ceremony. In their original context, they describe Solomon’s bed surrounded by guards, but in this funerary context, they symbolize spiritual protection for the deceased’s soul during the vulnerable transition from life to death. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:11-16 — These verses from Song of Songs describe the physical beauty of the beloved in detail from head to toe. In Ma’avar Yabok, they are reappropriated as a mystical template for the tahara washing ritual, with each body part mentioned corresponding to a section of the body to be washed, creating a correspondence between the physical washing and spiritual purification. | Cf. Song of Songs 7:5-6 — These verses from Song of Songs praising the beloved’s beauty are repurposed in Ma’avar Yabok for the washing ritual. In the original context they express romantic admiration, but in the funerary context, they create a dignified, sacred framework for handling the deceased’s body. | Cf. Exodus 14:31 — This verse from Exodus about the Israelites witnessing God’s power at the Red Sea is repurposed in Ma’avar Yabok specifically for washing the deceased’s hands. The symbolic connection lies in the ‘hand’ mentioned in the verse, creating a correspondence between the biblical text and the physical act being performed. | Cf. Psalm 84:2-8 — The verse about standing on level ground in the assembly echoes Psalm 84’s themes of journeying to God’s dwelling place. In Ma’avar Yabok, this takes on added significance as it relates to the soul’s journey after death. | Cf. Isaiah 6:2-3 — These verses from Isaiah’s throne vision are incorporated into Ma’avar Yabok’s washing ritual. In their original context, they describe Isaiah’s vision of God surrounded by seraphim proclaiming holiness. In the funerary context, they invoke angelic protection for the deceased and establish a connection between the deceased’s soul and the divine realm.

הִנֵּה מִטָּתוֹ שֶׁלִּשְׁלֹמֹה שִׁשִּׁים גִּבֹּרִים
סָבִיב לָהּ מִגִּבֹּרֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל: כֻּלָּם
אֲחֻזֵי חֶרֶב מְלֻמְּדֵי מִלְחָמָה אִישׁ
חַרְבּוֹ עַל יְרֵכוֹ מִפַּחַד בַּלֵּילוֹת:
רֹאשׁוֹ כֶּתֶם פָּז קְוֻצּוֹתָיו תַּלְתַּלִּים
שְׁחֹרוֹת כָּעוֹרֵב: רֹאשְׁךָ עָלַיִךְ
כַּכַּרְמֶל וְדַלַּת רֹאשֵׁךְ כָּאַרְגָּמָן
מֶלֶךְ אָסוּר בָּרְהָטִים: שְׂמֹאלוֹ
תַּחַת לְרֹאשִׁי וִימִינוֹ תְּחַבְּקֵנִי:
יָבוֹא שָׁלוֹם יָנוּחוּ עַל מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם
הֹלֵךְ נְכֹחוֹ: מָה אָדָם וַתֵּדָעֵהוּ בֶּן
אֱנוֹשׁ וַתְּחַשְּׁבֵהוּ: וַתְּחַסְּרֵהוּ מְעַט
מֵאֱלֹהִים וְכָבוֹד וְהָדָר תְּעַטְּרֵהוּ:
לַאדֹנָי אֱלֹהֵינוּ הָרַחֲמִים וְהַסְּלִחוֹת
כִּי מָרַדְנוּ בּוֹ (ויאמר י״ג מדות
בכורא בתורה): שְׁנֵי שָׁדַיִךְ כִּשְׁנֵי
עֳפָרִים תְּאוֹמֵי צְבִיָּה: שָׁרְרֵךְ אַגַּן
הַסַּהַר אַל־יֶחְסַר הַמָּזֶג בִּטְנֵךְ
עֲרֵמַת חִטִּים סוּגָה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּים:
מַעְיָו עֶשֶׁת שֵׁן מְעֻלֶּפֶת סַפִּירִים:
וַיַּרְא יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַיָּד הַגְּדֹלָה אֲשֶׁר
עָשָׂה יְיָ בְּמִצְרַיִם וַיִּירְאוּ הָעָם
אֶת יְיָ וַיַּאֲמִינוּ בַּיהוָה וּבְמֹשֶׁה
עַבְדּוֹ: כִּי בְיָד חֲזָקָה יְשַׁלְּחֵם וּבְיָד
חֲזָקָה יְגָרְשֵׁם מֵאַרְצוֹ: יָדָיו גְּלִילֵי
זָהָב מְמֻלָּאִים בַּתַּרְשִׁישׁ: חֲמוּקֵי
יְרֵכַיִךְ כְּמוֹ חֲלָאִים מַעֲשֵׂה יְדֵי
אָמָּן: וּבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל יֹצְאִים בְּיָד
רָמָה: וְזָכַרְתִּי אֶת בְּרִיתִי יַעֲקוֹב
וְאַף אֶת בְּרִיתִי יִצְחָק וְאַף אֶת
בְּרִיתִי אַבְרָהָם אֶזְכֹּר וְהָאָרֶץ
אֶזְכֹּר: שׁוֹקָיו עַמּוּדֵי שֵׁשׁ מְיֻסָּדִים
עַל אַדְנֵי פָז מַרְאֵהוּ כַּלְּבָנוֹן בָּחוּר
כָּאֲרָזִים: רַגְלִי עָמְדָה בְּמִישׁוֹר
בְּמַקְהֲלִים אֲבָרֵךְ יְיָ: רַגְלֵי חֲסִידָיו
יִשְׁמֹר: פָּנִים בְּפָנִים דִּבֶּר יְיָ עִמָּכֶם
בָּהָר מִתּוֹךְ הָאֵשׁ: אָנֹכִי עֹמֵד בֵּין
יְיָ וּבֵינֵיכֶם בָּעֵת הַהִיא לְהַגִּיד
לָכֶם אֶת דְּבַר יְיָ כִּי יְרֵאתֶם מִפְּנֵי
הָאֵשׁ וְלֹא עֲלִיתֶם בָּהָר לֵאמֹר:

Behold, Solomon's bed,[3] surrounded by sixty mighty men from the mighty ones of Israel. All of them wielding swords, skilled in battle, each with his sword upon his thigh because of fear in the nights. His head is like fine gold, his locks are wavy, black as a raven. Your head upon you is like Carmel, and the hair of your head like purple; a king is bound in the tresses. His left hand is under my head, and his right hand embraces me. Let peace come, let them rest on their beds, he who walks uprightly. What is man that You take knowledge of him, or the son of man that You think of him? You have made him a little lower than God, and crowned him with glory and honor. To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness,[1] for we have rebelled against Him (and he shall recite the Thirteen Attributes as one reading from the Torah). Your two breasts are like two fawns, twins of a gazelle. Your navel is like a round goblet that never lacks mixed wine; your belly is like a heap of wheat encircled with lilies. His stomach is like polished ivory overlaid with sapphires. And Israel saw the great hand which the LORD performed in Egypt, and the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in Moses His servant. For with a strong hand he will send them away, and with a strong hand he will drive them out of his land. His hands are rods of gold filled with beryl. The curves of your thighs are like jewels,[2] the work of a master craftsman. And the children of Israel went out with a high hand. And I will remember My covenant with Jacob, and also My covenant with Isaac, and also My covenant with Abraham I will remember, and I will remember the land. His legs are pillars of marble set upon sockets of fine gold; his appearance is like Lebanon, choice as cedars. My foot stands on level ground; in the congregations I will bless the LORD. He preserves the feet of His faithful ones. The LORD spoke to you face to face on the mountain from the midst of the fire. I stood between the LORD and you at that time, to declare to you the word of the LORD;

[3]The compilation of biblical verses in this passage serves a specific ritual purpose in Ma'avar Yabok. These verses are to be recited during the tahara (ritual washing of the deceased), with different verses corresponding to different body parts, following a top-down anatomical order.

[1]This verse from Daniel 9:9 introduces a transition in the ritual, where the focus shifts from describing the body to invoking divine mercy. The instruction to recite the Thirteen Attributes follows naturally from this appeal to divine compassion.

[2]The alternation between masculine and feminine imagery throughout this passage reflects the mystical concept of the soul's fluid nature. In kabbalistic thought, the soul contains both masculine and feminine aspects regardless of the deceased's biological gender.

עֵינָיו כְּיוֹנִים עַל אֲפִיקֵי מָיִם
רֹחֲצוֹת בֶּחָלָב יֹשְׁבוֹת עַל מִלֵּאת:
לְחָיָו כַּעֲרוּגַת הַבֹּשֶׂם מִגְדְּלוֹת
מֶרְקָחִים שִׂפְתוֹתָיו שׁוֹשַׁנִּים נֹטְפוֹת
מוֹר עֹבֵר: כִּי אֶרְאֶה שָׁמֶיךָ מַעֲשֵׂי
אֶצְבְּעֹתֶיךָ יָרֵחַ וְכוֹכָבִים אֲשֶׁר
כּוֹנָנְתָּה: בְּיָדְךָ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי
פָּדִיתָה אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת: יָאֵר יְיָ
פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ: יִשָּׂא יְיָ פָּנָיו
אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם: [i]

for you were afraid because of the fire, and did not go up into the mountain, saying: His eyes are like doves by streams of water, washed with milk, fitly set. His cheeks are like a bed of spices, like banks of scented herbs; his lips are lilies, dripping flowing myrrh. When I consider Your heavens, the work of Your fingers, the moon and the stars, which You have ordained. Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD God of truth. May the LORD make His face shine upon you, and be gracious to you. May the LORD lift up His countenance upon you, and give you peace.[1] 4400R 4405R

ובשפיכת ט׳ קבין[ii] אחר הרחיצה[iii] יאמר:[iv]

And when pouring[2] the nine measures of water[3] after the washing, he shall say: 4410R

[1]The passage concludes with the Priestly Blessing from Numbers 6:24-26, which invokes divine light, grace, and peace upon the deceased. This blessing forms a fitting conclusion to the ritual washing prayers, expressing hope for the soul's peaceful journey.

[2]This ritual pouring of water represents the final and most significant purification act in the tahara process. In kabbalistic understanding, it symbolizes the complete spiritual cleansing of the deceased, washing away any remaining spiritual impurities before burial and facilitating the soul's transition to the next world.

[3]The Hebrew term 'kav' (קב) is a specific volume measurement in rabbinic literature. Rather than converting to modern measurements, I've rendered it as 'measures' to preserve the ritual significance of the specific number nine, which is important in kabbalistic thought as representing the nine sefirot below Keter or the nine chambers of divine judgment.

[i]Cf. Song of Songs — These verses from Song of Songs appear in Ma'avar Yabok specifically as part of the tahara ritual (washing of the deceased), where different biblical verses are recited for different body parts, following a top-down order from head to feet. This practice is based on the kabbalistic concept that the human form mirrors divine structures. | Cf. Isaiah 57:2 — This verse appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok's funeral prayers to express hope for the deceased's peaceful transition. It is particularly significant as it connects to the book's central metaphor of 'crossing over' to peaceful rest. | Cf. Psalm 8:5-6 — These verses reflect on the dignity of the human being despite mortality. In the context of tahara rituals, they remind those performing the washing of the inherent dignity of the deceased as a being created in the divine image. | Cf. Exodus 14:31 — This verse about Israel witnessing God's 'great hand' in Egypt is recited during the washing of the deceased's hands, creating a correspondence between the physical act of washing and spiritual redemption. | Cf. Leviticus 26:42 — This verse invoking God's covenant with the patriarchs serves as a plea for divine mercy for the deceased, based on ancestral merit rather than personal worthiness.

[ii]The phrase 'ט׳ קבין' (nine kav) refers to a specific measurement of water used in the tahara ritual (purification of the deceased). A kav is an ancient measure of volume approximately equal to 1.2-1.4 liters, making the total volume around 10-12 liters. This specific quantity has ritual significance in Jewish law.

[iii]The term 'רחיצה' (rechitzah/washing) here refers to the initial cleaning of the deceased's body, which is followed by the ritual pouring of the nine measures of water as the culminating purification act of the tahara process.

[iv]Cf. Chapter 12 of the Third Discourse — The passage refers to the ritual of pouring nine measures (kav) of water over the deceased's body as the final step of the tahara (purification) ritual. Chapter 12 of the Third Discourse in Ma'avar Yabok details the types of aromatic substances that should be added to this water and their spiritual significance. | Cf. Chapter 10 of the Third Discourse — This brief instruction is directly connected to Chapter 10 of the Third Discourse in Ma'avar Yabok, which explains that the nine measures of water represent the final spiritual purification of the deceased, symbolically washing away any remaining spiritual impurities before burial.

אִם רָחַץ אֲדֹנָי אֶת צֹאַת בְּנוֹת צִיּוֹן
וְאֶת דְּמֵי יְרוּשָׁלַם יָדִיחַ מִקִּרְבָּהּ
בְּרוּחַ מִשְׁפָּט וּבְרוּחַ בָּעֵר: [i] וַיִּרְא
רֵאשִׁית לוֹ כִּי שָׁם חֶלְקַת מְחֹקֵק
סָפוּן וַיֹּתֵא רָאשֵׁי עָם צְדָקַת יְיָ
עָשָׂה וּמִשְׁפָּטָיו עִם יִשְׂרָאֵל: עֵינָיו
כְּיוֹנִים עַל אֲפִיקֵי מָיִם רֹחֲצוֹת
בֶּחָלָב יֹשְׁבוֹת עַל מִלֵּאת: [ii] אַפֵּךְ
כְּמִגְדַּל הַלְּבָנוֹן צוֹפֶה פְּנֵי דַמָּשֶׂק:
כֹּה אָמַר יְיָ הִנְנִי שָׁב שְׁבוּת אָהֳלֵי
יַעֲקוֹב וּמִשְׁכְּנֹתָיו אֲרַחֵם וְנִבְנְתָה
עִיר עַל תִּלָּהּ וְאַרְמוֹן עַל מִשְׁפָּטוֹ
יֵשֵׁב: שׂוֹשׂ אָשִׂישׂ בַּיהוָה תָּגֵל נַפְשִׁי
בֵּאלֹהַי כִּי הִלְבִּישַׁנִי בִּגְדֵי יֶשַׁע
מְעִיל צְדָקָה יְעָטָנִי [iii] כֶּחָתָן יְכַהֵן
פְּאֵר וְכַכַּלָּה תַּעֲדֶה כֵלֶיהָ: יְחִיוּ
מֵתֶיךָ נְבֵלָתִי יְקוּמוּן הָקִיצוּ וְרַנְּנוּ
שֹׁכְנֵי עָפָר כִּי טַל אוֹרוֹת טַלֶּךָ
וָאָרֶץ רְפָאִים תַּפִּיל: [iv] וּמֹשֶׁה
עָלָה אֶל הָאֱלֹהִים וַיִּקְרָא אֵלָיו יְיָ
מִן הָהָר לֵאמֹר כֹּה תֹאמַר לְבֵית
יַעֲקֹב וְתַגִּיד לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל: אַתֶּם
רְאִיתֶם אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתִי לְמִצְרַיִם
וָאֶשָּׂא אֶתְכֶם עַל כַּנְפֵי נְשָׁרִים
וָאָבֵא אֶתְכֶם אֵלָי: וְעַתָּה אִם שָׁמוֹעַ
תִּשְׁמְעוּ בְקֹלִי וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת בְּרִיתִי

When the Lord has washed away the filth of the daughters of Zion[4] and cleansed the bloodstains of Jerusalem from her midst, by a spirit of judgment and a spirit of burning. And he saw that the first portion was his, for there the commander's allotment was reserved; and he came with the heads of the people, he executed the justice of the LORD, and His judgments with Israel. His eyes are like doves by streams of water, washed with milk, sitting by fullness.[1] Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon overlooking Damascus. Thus says the LORD: Behold, I will restore the fortunes of Jacob's tents, and have compassion on his dwellings; the city shall be built upon its mound, and the palace shall stand where it belongs. I will greatly rejoice in the LORD, my soul shall exult in my God; for He has clothed me with garments of salvation, He has wrapped me with a robe of righteousness, as a bridegroom puts on a priestly crown, and as a bride adorns herself with her jewels.[2] Your dead shall live, my corpse shall rise; awake and sing, you who dwell in the dust, for your dew is a dew of light,[3] and the earth shall cast out the shades. And Moses went up to God, and the LORD called to him from the mountain, saying, "Thus you shall say to the house of Jacob, and tell the children of Israel: You have seen what I did to

4135 4140 4145 4150 4155 4415R 4420R 4425R 4430R 4435R

[4]This opening verse establishes a parallel between divine purification described in Isaiah and the ritual purification (tahara) being performed. The washing of the deceased's body is understood as a reflection of divine cleansing.

[1]The verses from Song of Songs are used in a specific sequence during the tahara ritual, with different verses corresponding to different body parts. These poetic descriptions elevate the physical act of washing into a sacred ritual with mystical significance.

[2]This verse is particularly meaningful in the context of dressing the deceased in shrouds (tachrichim) after washing. Just as the physical body is dressed in white garments, the soul is understood to be clothed in 'garments of salvation' in the afterlife.

[3]The Hebrew phrase 'tal orot' (dew of light) has special kabbalistic significance, referring to the divine emanation that will resurrect the dead. This verse affirms the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection, providing comfort during the tahara ritual.

[i]This verse from Isaiah 4:4 appears at the beginning of the tahara ritual, specifically at the point when water is poured over the deceased. The imagery of divine cleansing creates a parallel between the physical act of washing the body and the spiritual purification of the soul.

[ii]This verse from Song of Songs 5:12 is specifically recited when washing the deceased's eyes during the tahara ritual. Ma'avar Yabok prescribes different verses from Song of Songs for different body parts, following a kabbalistic understanding that connects human anatomy to divine structures.

[iii]This verse from Isaiah 61:10 is recited during the tahara ritual after the washing is complete and when the deceased is being dressed in shrouds (tachrichim). The imagery of divine clothing creates a parallel between the physical dressing of the body and the spiritual garments that await the soul.

[iv]This powerful verse from Isaiah 26:19 about resurrection is included in the tahara ritual to emphasize that death is not the final state. The reference to 'dew of light' (טַל אוֹרוֹת) has particular kabbalistic significance, representing the divine emanation that will bring about resurrection.

וְהְיִיתֶם לִי סְגֻלָּה מִכָּל הָעַמִּים
כִּי לִי כָּל הָאָרֶץ: וְאַתֶּם תִּהְיוּ
לִי מַמְלֶכֶת כֹּהֲנִים וְגוֹי קָדוֹשׁ
אֵלֶּה הַדְּבָרִים אֲשֶׁר תְּדַבֵּר אֶל
בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל: וַיְצַוְּנוּ יְהוָה לַעֲשׂוֹת
אֶת כָּל הַחֻקִּים הָאֵלֶּה לְיִרְאָה
אֶת יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ לְטוֹב לָנוּ כָּל
הַיָּמִים לְחַיֹּתֵנוּ כְּהַיּוֹם הַזֶּה: וְאַתֶּם
הַדְּבֵקִים בַּיהוָה אֱלֹהֵיכֶם חַיִּים
כֻּלְּכֶם הַיּוֹם: לֹא אָמוּת כִּי אֶחְיֶה
וַאֲסַפֵּר מַעֲשֵׂי יָהּ:[i][ii]

the Egyptians, and how I bore you on eagles' wings and brought you to Myself. Now therefore, if you will indeed obey My voice and keep My covenant, then you shall be a special treasure to Me above all peoples; for all the earth is Mine. And you shall be to Me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation." These are the words which you shall speak to the children of Israel. And the LORD commanded us to observe all these statutes, to fear the LORD our God, for our good always, that He might preserve us alive, as it is to this day. But you who held fast to the LORD your God are alive, every one of you, today. I shall not die but live, and recount the deeds of the LORD.[1]

4160 4165 4440R 4445R 4450R

ולפי דרכי אתה למד מדברי
חכמי המשנה כי יביעו
ידברו גבוהה גבוהה בפסוקי

4170

And according to my approach, you can learn from the words of the Mishnaic Sages that they express and speak lofty matters through

[1]This concluding verse powerfully affirms continued existence despite physical death. In the context of tahara, it suggests that the soul lives on and will eventually be reunited with the body at resurrection.

[i]This final verse from Psalm 118:17 serves as a powerful conclusion to the tahara ritual verses, affirming the Jewish belief in continued existence after death and eventual resurrection. The phrase 'I shall not die but live' is particularly significant in the context of washing and preparing the deceased.

[ii]Cf. Isaiah 4:4 — This verse from Isaiah is used in the tahara ritual (purification of the deceased) to create a parallel between the physical washing of the body and spiritual purification. The imagery of divine cleansing provides spiritual comfort and theological framework for the ritual. | Cf. Deuteronomy 33:21 — This verse, part of Moses' final blessing, is included for its themes of divine justice and leadership. In the context of the tahara ritual, it suggests the deceased has received their proper portion and has completed their role in executing divine justice. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:12 — This verse from Song of Songs is specifically used during the tahara ritual when washing the deceased's eyes. In Ma'avar Yabok, different verses from Song of Songs are recited for different body parts, creating a mystical connection between physical washing and spiritual purification. | Cf. Song of Songs 7:5 — This verse continues the pattern of using Song of Songs passages to sanctify the washing of different body parts during the tahara ritual. The poetic descriptions from Song of Songs elevate the physical washing into a sacred act. | Cf. Jeremiah 30:18 — This prophetic verse of restoration connects the ritual washing to themes of renewal and rebuilding. In the context of tahara, it suggests that death is not final destruction but part of a divine process that ultimately leads to restoration. | Cf. Isaiah 61:10 — This verse is recited during the tahara ritual after washing, when the deceased is dressed in shrouds. It creates a parallel between the physical dressing of the body and the spiritual garments of salvation that await the soul. | Cf. Isaiah 26:19 — This powerful verse about resurrection provides theological comfort during the tahara ritual. It affirms the Jewish belief in resurrection of the dead, suggesting that the current state of death is temporary. | Cf. Exodus 19:3-6 — These verses from Exodus remind participants in the tahara ritual of the covenant relationship between God and Israel. They affirm that the deceased, as part of Israel, remains in this covenant relationship even after death. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:24 — This verse emphasizes that observance of commandments, including proper burial rituals, is for the welfare of the community. In the context of tahara, it suggests that proper ritual observance benefits both the deceased and the living. | Cf. Deuteronomy 4:4 — This verse emphasizes the spiritual life that comes from attachment to God. In the tahara context, it suggests that though physically dead, the soul of one who was attached to God continues to live. | Cf. Psalm 118:17 — This verse expresses hope in continued existence despite death. It reflects the Jewish theological view that the soul continues after death and will ultimately be reunited with the body at resurrection.

הנבואה ולא בדברי שיחתם
המהודרה[iii] הגם שהיא ספונה
וחשובה במתיבתא עילאה
ודרקיעא.[i] וברוך שבחר בהם
ובדבריהם:[iii][ii]

prophetic verses rather than through their own elegant discourse,[2] even though their discourse is treasured and esteemed in the celestial and heavenly academies.[1] Blessed is He who chose them and their words.

כי יפה אף נעים ללחוש עם
החולה המזמורים באלפא ביתא
כגון מזמור ל״ד לדוד בשנותו.
וקי״א אודה ה׳ בכל לבב. ומק״ה
תהלה לדוד. ובפרט מזמור כ״ה
אליך ה׳ נפשי אשא תמצא לעיל.
ויכוונו עמו להעלות בכח כללות
נשמתם חלקי נפש רוח נשמה
שבו בסוד אי״ק שהם אחדים
לנשמה עשיריות לרוח מאות
לנפש בסוד כהן לוי וישראל
כדאמרו בסוד מאה ברכות
בכל יום:[iv] ומעמד העשרה בכל
מקום מבטלים הפורענות שכן
אמרו במדרש תנחומא על פסוק
וירדו אחי יוסף עשרה וראיה

For it is beautiful and pleasant to whisper with the sick person psalms arranged in alphabetical order, such as Psalm 34 (“Of David, when he changed his behavior”), Psalm 111 (“I will praise the Lord with my whole heart”), and Psalm 145 (“A praise of David”). In particular, Psalm 25 (“Unto You, O Lord, I lift up my soul”), which can be found above. Those attending should join with the sick person in focusing their intention on elevating through the collective power of their souls the components of nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul) within him, according to the mystery of AI”K,[2] in which units correspond to neshamah, tens to ruach, and hundreds to nefesh, in accordance with the mystery of Kohen, Levi, and Israel,[3] as they said concerning the mystery of the

[2]This passage reflects a view about the relative authority of different types of sacred texts, with the author suggesting that the Mishnaic sages themselves preferred to express their deepest insights through quotations from prophetic scripture rather than through their own formulations, despite the reverence their personal teachings received.

[1]The original uses two synonymous terms (‘metivta ila’ah’ and ‘derakia’) that both refer to the concept of heavenly academies where the souls of departed sages continue their Torah study after death. This notion appears frequently in rabbinic literature, particularly in mystical contexts.

[2]AI”K refers to a kabbalistic method of organizing the Hebrew alphabet into groups based on numerical values. This system is fundamental to many kabbalistic practices involving letter permutations and gematria (numerical equivalences).

[3]This refers to the traditional tripartite division of the Jewish people (priests, Levites, and Israelites), which the author correlates to the three levels of the soul. This creates a cosmic correspondence between social structure and spiritual reality.

[i]The author establishes a hierarchy of textual authority, with prophetic scripture ranking above rabbinic discourse, while still acknowledging the value of rabbinic teachings.

[ii]These terms refer to the celestial academy and heavenly yeshiva where, according to rabbinic tradition, the souls of departed sages continue their Torah study. This concept appears in several Talmudic and midrashic sources, notably in Bava Metzia 85b-86a.

[iii]This is a formulaic blessing phrase that echoes liturgical language used when concluding Torah readings, here repurposed to praise God’s choice of the sages and their teachings.

[iv]Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Bava Metzia 85b-86a — The author is contrasting the elevated status of prophetic scripture with the words of the sages, while still acknowledging that these sages’ teachings are valued in heavenly academies, alluding to the Talmudic concept that deceased scholars continue their studies in celestial academies. | Cf. Pirke Avot 6:3 — The concluding blessing formula in this passage echoes traditional rabbinic phrases of blessing God for choosing the sages and their teachings, specifically reminiscent of formulations found in Pirke Avot.

[v]This passage explains a kabbalistic technique for healing using psalms in alphabetical order. It employs a complex system where units (ones) correlate to neshamah (highest soul), tens to ruach (spirit), and hundreds to nefesh (vital soul), which parallel the three divisions of Jewish society: Kohen, Levi, and Israel. This system is connected to the daily requirement of reciting one hundred blessings.

מסדום דכתיב לא אשחית בעבור
4195 העשרה.[v] ומצורף לכוונה הנז׳
ודאי יועילו וגם יצילו. עוד כלך
לדרך אחרת יכוונו באחדים
לעלוי הנפש הנכלל מכללות
קטן ובעשיריות לעולי הרוח
4200 הנכלל מכללות אותיות העשר
ובמאות לעלוי הנשמה הנכללת
מכללות גדול עד סוף האלף
בסוד נעוץ סופן בתחלתן במו
שאמרו על כללות מלכות ת״ת
4205 בינה. והנה גם הפסוקים של
אלפא ביתא שהעלינו בסוף מנחת
אהרן מכוונים לזה הגם כי שם
לא היה לזאת מגמתנו וכל מבין
לאשורו יוכל לסדר אלפא ביתא
4210 יותר מכוונת והמעיין בפרדס
בשער האותיות ובספר גינת אגוז
חלק שני בשער האותיות ימצא
ע״פ ההקדמות שבאו שם דברינו
נכוחים למבין וישרים למוצאי
4215 דעת:[ii i]

one hundred blessings recited daily. The presence 4475R
of ten individuals in any place nullifies calamity, as
stated in Midrash Tanchuma regarding the verse
“And Joseph’s brothers went down, ten of them,”
with proof from Sodom, where it is written: “I
will not destroy for the sake of the ten.” When 4480R
combined with the aforementioned intention, these
will certainly help and also save. Additionally, as an
alternative approach, they may direct their intention
with the units toward elevating the nefesh, which is
encompassed within the small totality; with the tens 4485R
toward elevating the ruach, which is encompassed
within the totality of the ten letters; and with the
hundreds toward elevating the neshamah, which is
encompassed within the great totality extending
to the end of the alef, according to the mystery of 4490R
“their end is wedged in their beginning,”[1] as they
said regarding the totality of Malkhut, Tiferet, and
Binah. Indeed, the alphabetically arranged verses
that we included at the end of Minchat Aharon[2] are
directed toward this purpose, although that was 4495R
not our primary intention there. Anyone who truly
understands can arrange an alphabetical order with
even more focused intention, and one who studies
the Pardes in the Gate of Letters and the second
part of Sefer Ginat Egoz in the Gate of Letters will 4500R
find, based on the principles presented there, that

[1] This phrase ‘na’utz sofan b’techilatan’ comes from the Sefer Yetzirah, a foundational kabbalistic text, and refers to the cyclical nature of reality where the highest and lowest levels are interconnected. Here it’s applied to the relationship between the different soul components and divine attributes.

[2] Minchat Aharon is another work by the same author, Aaron Berechia of Modena. This self-reference helps establish the interconnection between his various works on related mystical practices.

[vi] The author cites rabbinic precedent for the power of ten individuals (a minyan) to nullify divine punishment, drawing on both the Midrash Tanchuma about Joseph’s brothers and the story of Sodom, where God agrees not to destroy the city if ten righteous people can be found.

[i] The text references several kabbalistic works including Pardes (likely Pardes Rimmonim by Moses Cordovero) and Ginat Egoz, directing readers to these sources for deeper understanding of the letter mysticism that underlies these healing practices. The author also mentions his own work Minchat Aharon, revealing how these texts form an interconnected body of kabbalistic literature.

[ii] Cf. Ma’avar Yabok, first discourse, section on visiting the sick — The passage connects to the broader theme in Ma’avar Yabok about proper spiritual care for the sick, specifically how to use psalms with kabbalistic intentions to elevate the soul of the ill person. | Cf. Minchat Aharon — The author explicitly references another of his own works, Minchat Aharon, which apparently contains alphabetically arranged verses that serve a similar purpose to what he’s describing here. | Cf. Pardes Rimmonim by Moses Cordovero — The author refers readers to Pardes Rimmonim (likely the work by Moses Cordovero) for deeper understanding of the mystical properties of Hebrew letters that underlie the practices described. | Cf. Sefer Ginat Egoz — The author refers readers to Sefer Ginat Egoz for further exploration of the mystical properties of Hebrew letters that underlie the practices described.

our words are straightforward to the discerning and upright to those who find knowledge.

מלבד מה שהעלנו על ספר[i] מהסדרים שבאו למעלה[ii] לאמר לחולה בחליו ראינו עתה להוסיף לקח ולומר:[iii iv]

In addition to what we have recorded from the liturgical orders[1] that appear above for recitation to the sick in their illness,[2] we have now decided to add instruction and say: 4505R

(תהלים לד) לְדָוִד בְּשַׁנּוֹתוֹ אֶת־טַעְמוֹ לִפְנֵי אֲבִימֶלֶךְ וַיְגָרְשֵׁהוּ וַיֵּלַךְ: אֲבָרְכָה אֶת־יְיָ בְּכָל־עֵת תָּמִיד תְּהִלָּתוֹ בְּפִי: בַּיהוָה תִּתְהַלֵּל נַפְשִׁי יִשְׁמְעוּ עֲנָוִים וְיִשְׂמָחוּ: גַּדְּלוּ לַיְיָ אִתִּי וּנְרוֹמְמָה שְׁמוֹ יַחְדָּו: דָּרַשְׁתִּי אֶת־יְיָ וְעָנָנִי וּמִכָּל־מְגוּרוֹתַי הִצִּילָנִי: הִבִּיטוּ אֵלָיו וְנָהָרוּ וּפְנֵיהֶם אַל־יֵחְפָּרוּ: זֶה עָנִי קָרָא וַיְיָ שָׁמַע וּמִכָּל־צָרוֹתָיו הוֹשִׁיעוֹ: חֹנֶה מַלְאַךְ־יְיָ סָבִיב לִירֵאָיו וַיְחַלְּצֵם: טַעֲמוּ וּרְאוּ כִּי־טוֹב יְיָ אַשְׁרֵי הַגֶּבֶר יֶחֱסֶה־בּוֹ: יְרָאוּ אֶת־יְיָ קְדֹשָׁיו כִּי־אֵין מַחְסוֹר לִירֵאָיו: כְּפִירִים רָשׁוּ וְרָעֵבוּ וְדֹרְשֵׁי יְיָ לֹא־יַחְסְרוּ כָל־טוֹב: לְכוּ־בָנִים שִׁמְעוּ־לִי יִרְאַת יְיָ אֲלַמֶּדְכֶם: מִי־זֶה הָאִישׁ הֶחָפֵץ חַיִּים אֹהֵב יָמִים

(Psalm 34) Of David, when he changed his behavior before Abimelech, who drove him away, and he departed. I will bless the LORD at all times;[3] His praise shall continually be in my mouth. My soul shall glory in the LORD; the humble shall hear and rejoice. Magnify the LORD with me, and let us exalt His name together. I sought the LORD, and He answered me, and delivered me from all my fears. They looked to Him and were radiant, and their faces were not ashamed. This poor man called, and the LORD heard, and saved him from all his troubles. The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear Him, and rescues them. Taste and see that the LORD is good;[4] blessed is the man who takes refuge in Him. Fear the LORD, you His holy ones, for there is no want for those who fear Him. Young lions may grow weak and hungry, but those who seek the LORD shall not lack any good thing. Come, children, listen to me; I will teach you the fear of the LORD. Who is 4510R 4515R 4520R 4525R

[1] The Hebrew term "sedarim" (סדרים) refers to the structured prayer sequences that make up a significant portion of Ma'avar Yabok. These are organized collections of psalms, biblical verses, and prayers designed for specific situations related to illness and approaching death.

[2] This transition indicates that the text is now moving from the previously presented prayer sequences to additional prayers specifically designed for recitation to or by the sick person.

[3] This opening declaration establishes a key theme relevant to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness and death: maintaining constant devotion to God regardless of circumstances. For the sick or dying person reciting this psalm, this verse becomes a spiritual commitment to maintain praise even through suffering.

[4] The sensory metaphor of 'tasting' divine goodness suggests direct spiritual experience rather than abstract knowledge. In kabbalistic contexts like Ma'avar Yabok, such metaphors would be understood as invitations to mystical perception, particularly relevant during transitional states like serious illness or approaching death when spiritual awareness may be heightened.

[i] Literally "what we have raised to the book," an idiomatic expression meaning "what we have written/recorded."

[ii] Refers to the previously recorded prayer sequences (sedarim) presented earlier in the text.

[iii] The phrase "to add instruction" (להוסיף לקח) has resonance with Proverbs 1:5, suggesting these additional prayers offer deeper wisdom or instruction.

[iv] Cf. Proverbs 1:5 — This subtle biblical allusion frames the additional prayers not merely as supplementary material but as deeper wisdom that builds upon the previous sections. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section — The phrase "liturgical orders that appear above" directly references the book's own structure, showing how these additional prayers are meant to supplement the formal sedarim already presented.

לִרְאוֹת טוֹב: נְצֹר לְשׁוֹנְךָ מֵרָע
וּשְׂפָתֶיךָ מִדַּבֵּר מִרְמָה: סוּר
מֵרָע וַעֲשֵׂה־טוֹב בַּקֵּשׁ שָׁלוֹם
וְרָדְפֵהוּ: עֵינֵי יְיָ אֶל־צַדִּיקִים
וְאָזְנָיו אֶל־שַׁוְעָתָם: פְּנֵי יְיָ בְּעֹשֵׂי
רָע לְהַכְרִית מֵאֶרֶץ זִכְרָם:
צָעֲקוּ וַיהוָה שָׁמֵעַ וּמִכָּל־צָרוֹתָם
הִצִּילָם: קָרוֹב יְיָ לְנִשְׁבְּרֵי־לֵב
וְאֶת־דַּכְּאֵי־רוּחַ יוֹשִׁיעַ: רַבּוֹת
רָעוֹת צַדִּיק וּמִכֻּלָּם יַצִּילֶנּוּ יְיָ:
שֹׁמֵר כָּל־עַצְמוֹתָיו אַחַת מֵהֵנָּה לֹא
נִשְׁבָּרָה: תְּמוֹתֵת רָשָׁע רָעָה וְשׂנְאֵי
צַדִּיק יֶאְשָׁמוּ: פּוֹדֶה יְיָ נֶפֶשׁ עֲבָדָיו
וְלֹא יֶאְשְׁמוּ כָּל־חֹסִים בּוֹ:[i]

the man who desires life, and loves many days, that he may see good? Guard your tongue from evil, and your lips from speaking deceit. Turn away from evil and do good; seek peace and pursue it. The eyes of 4530R
the LORD are toward the righteous, and His ears are open to their cry. The face of the LORD is against evildoers, to cut off the memory of them from the earth. The righteous cry out, and the LORD hears, and delivers them from all their troubles. The LORD 4535R
is near to the brokenhearted, and saves those who are crushed in spirit. Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the LORD delivers him from them all. He preserves all his bones; not one of them is broken. Evil shall slay the wicked, and those who hate the 4540R
righteous will be condemned. The LORD redeems the soul of His servants,[1] and none who take refuge in Him shall be condemned.

(תהלים קיא) הַלְלוּ יָהּ אוֹדֶה
יְיָ בְּכָל־לֵבָב בְּסוֹד יְשָׁרִים
וְעֵדָה: [ii]גְּדֹלִים מַעֲשֵׂי יְיָ דְּרוּשִׁים
לְכָל־חֶפְצֵיהֶם: הוֹד־וְהָדָר פָּעֳלוֹ

(Psalm 111) Hallelujah! I will praise the LORD with my whole heart[2] in the assembly of the upright and in 4545R
the congregation. The works of the LORD are great, sought out by all who delight in them.[3] His work is

[1]The psalm concludes with divine redemption of the soul, a theme perfectly aligned with Ma'avar Yabok's central metaphor of 'crossing over' from life to death. This final verse would provide comfort that the soul's journey after death remains under divine protection and care.

[2]The Hebrew בְּכָל־לֵבָב literally means 'with all heart,' emphasizing complete devotion. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this whole-hearted praise represents the ideal spiritual state for one approaching death—fully aligned with divine will.

[3]The Hebrew דְּרוּשִׁים (derushim) implies not just casual interest but deep investigation or study. This suggests that proper appreciation of divine works requires active engagement, similar to how Ma'avar Yabok encourages active preparation for death rather than passive acceptance.

[i]Cf. I Samuel 21:10-15 — This psalm is identified as David's response to his deliverance from danger when he pretended to be insane before the Philistine king. In Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm is recommended for recitation by or for the sick, suggesting that just as David found divine deliverance in his distress, so might those facing illness or approaching death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences reflects the belief that psalms expressing both distress and divine deliverance are particularly appropriate for those experiencing illness. The psalm's themes of divine protection, answered prayer, and deliverance from troubles resonate with the book's theological framework that proper spiritual preparation can facilitate healing or a peaceful transition at death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Shabbat 30b — The psalm's emphasis on rejoicing in God and proclaiming His praise aligns with the rabbinic understanding that joyful devotion creates a connection to the divine presence. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that even in times of illness or approaching death, maintaining spiritual joy can facilitate divine presence and protection. | Cf. Zohar III:231a — The psalm's mention of 'The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear Him' (verse 8) would be interpreted in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework as referring to the protective spiritual forces that surround those who maintain proper spiritual devotion, particularly relevant for the sick and dying who might feel vulnerable to negative spiritual forces.

[ii]This psalm begins with a personal declaration of praise ('I will praise') but immediately places this individual devotion within the context of the community ('in the assembly of the upright and in the congregation'). This balance between personal and communal worship is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, which addresses both the individual's spiritual preparation for death and the community's role in facilitating this transition.

וְצִדְקָתוֹ עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד: זֵכֶר עָשָׂה
לְנִפְלְאוֹתָיו חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם יְיָ[iii]:
טֶרֶף נָתַן לִירֵאָיו יִזְכֹּר לְעוֹלָם
בְּרִיתוֹ[i]: כֹּחַ מַעֲשָׂיו הִגִּיד לְעַמּוֹ
לָתֵת לָהֶם נַחֲלַת גּוֹיִם: מַעֲשֵׂי יָדָיו
אֱמֶת וּמִשְׁפָּט נֶאֱמָנִים כָּל־פִּקּוּדָיו:
סְמוּכִים לָעַד לְעוֹלָם עֲשׂוּיִם
בֶּאֱמֶת וְיָשָׁר: פְּדוּת שָׁלַח לְעַמּוֹ
צִוָּה־לְעוֹלָם בְּרִיתוֹ קָדוֹשׁ
וְנוֹרָא שְׁמוֹ: רֵאשִׁית חָכְמָה יִרְאַת
יְיָ[ii] שֵׂכֶל טוֹב לְכָל־עֹשֵׂיהֶם תְּהִלָּתוֹ
עֹמֶדֶת לָעַד[iii]:

splendid and majestic, and His righteousness endures forever. He has made His wonders to be remembered; the LORD is gracious and compassionate. He has given food to those who fear Him;[1] He will remember His covenant forever. He has shown His people the power of His works, by giving them the inheritance of the nations. The works of His hands are truth and justice; all His precepts are trustworthy. They are established forever and ever, done in truth and uprightness. He has sent redemption to His people; He has ordained His covenant forever; holy and awesome is His name. The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom; good understanding have all who practice them.[2] His praise endures forever.

(תהלים קמה) תְּהִלָּה לְדָוִד
אֲרוֹמִמְךָ אֱלוֹהַי הַמֶּלֶךְ וַאֲבָרְכָה
שִׁמְךָ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד: בְּכָל־יוֹם
אֲבָרְכֶךָּ וַאֲהַלְלָה שִׁמְךָ לְעוֹלָם
וָעֶד: גָּדוֹל יְיָ וּמְהֻלָּל מְאֹד
וְלִגְדֻלָּתוֹ אֵין חֵקֶר: דּוֹר לְדוֹר
יְשַׁבַּח מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וּגְבוּרֹתֶיךָ יַגִּידוּ:

(Psalm 145) A Praise of David. I will exalt You, my God, the King, and I will bless Your name forever and ever. Every day I will bless You, and I will praise Your name forever and ever. Great is the LORD and highly praised, and His greatness is unfathomable. Generation to generation shall praise Your works, and they shall declare Your mighty acts.

[1] The Hebrew טֶרֶף (teref) literally means 'prey' or 'torn food,' but is used metaphorically for sustenance or provision. This vivid imagery of God as provider resonates with Ma'avar Yabok's theology that God provides spiritual sustenance through both life and the transition of death.

[2] The Hebrew construction לְכָל־עֹשֵׂיהֶם can be understood as either 'all who practice them' (referring to the precepts) or 'all who do His commandments.' I've chosen the first interpretation, but both convey the psalm's emphasis on active practice rather than mere intellectual acknowledgment—a theme that aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's practical guidance for end-of-life rituals.

[i] The phrase 'He has made His wonders to be remembered' carries special significance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as remembrance plays a crucial role in Jewish mourning practices. The psalm suggests that God's own actions establish a pattern of remembrance that the community then follows in commemorating both divine acts and departed souls.

[ii] The covenant relationship emphasized here would be particularly comforting to the dying person, as it affirms that God's commitment extends beyond the individual's lifetime. This provides reassurance that the soul remains in covenant relationship with God even after death.

[iii] This famous verse about the fear of God being the beginning of wisdom takes on deeper significance in the context of approaching death, when one faces the ultimate encounter with divine judgment. Ma'avar Yabok consistently presents proper spiritual preparation for death as the highest wisdom.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — Psalm 111 appears in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer sequences specifically for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine faithfulness, covenant remembrance, and enduring righteousness provide spiritual comfort for those facing illness or approaching death. The psalm's emphasis on God's redemptive power and provision for those who fear Him makes it particularly appropriate in this context. | Cf. Book of Psalms — This is a complete quotation of Psalm 111, one of the acrostic psalms where each half-verse begins with successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm's themes of divine remembrance, covenant faithfulness, and enduring righteousness would be especially comforting to the sick or dying, assuring them of God's continued care. | Cf. Siddur (Jewish prayer book) — Psalm 111 is part of the liturgical recitation of Hallel on festivals and Rosh Chodesh. In Ma'avar Yabok, its inclusion in prayers for the sick connects the individual's experience to the communal celebration of divine deliverance, suggesting that even in illness, one remains part of the covenant community praising God.

הֲדַר כְּבוֹד הוֹדֶךָ וְדִבְרֵי
נִפְלְאוֹתֶיךָ אָשִׂיחָה: וֶעֱזוּז
נוֹרְאוֹתֶיךָ יֹאמֵרוּ וּגְדוּלָּתְךָ
[וּגְדוּלָּתְךָ] אֲסַפְּרֶנָּה: זֵכֶר
רַב־טוּבְךָ יַבִּיעוּ וְצִדְקָתְךָ
יְרַנֵּנוּ: חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם יְיָ אֶרֶךְ
אַפַּיִם וּגְדָל־חָסֶד[i]: טוֹב־יְיָ לַכֹּל
וְרַחֲמָיו עַל־כָּל־מַעֲשָׂיו: יוֹדוּךָ יְיָ
כָּל־מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וַחֲסִידֶיךָ יְבָרְכוּכָה:
כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתְךָ יֹאמֵרוּ וּגְבוּרָתְךָ
יְדַבֵּרוּ: לְהוֹדִיעַ לִבְנֵי הָאָדָם
גְּבוּרֹתָיו וּכְבוֹד הֲדַר מַלְכוּתוֹ:
מַלְכוּתְךָ מַלְכוּת כָּל־עֹלָמִים
וּמֶמְשַׁלְתְּךָ בְּכָל־דּוֹר וָדוֹר:
סוֹמֵךְ יְיָ לְכָל־הַנֹּפְלִים וְזוֹקֵף
לְכָל־הַכְּפוּפִים[ii]: עֵינֵי־כֹל
אֵלֶיךָ יְשַׂבֵּרוּ וְאַתָּה נוֹתֵן־לָהֶם
אֶת־אָכְלָם בְּעִתּוֹ: פּוֹתֵחַ אֶת־יָדֶךָ
וּמַשְׂבִּיעַ לְכָל־חַי רָצוֹן: צַדִּיק יְיָ
בְּכָל־דְּרָכָיו וְחָסִיד בְּכָל־מַעֲשָׂיו:
קָרוֹב יְיָ לְכָל־קֹרְאָיו לְכֹל אֲשֶׁר
יִקְרָאֻהוּ בֶאֱמֶת: רְצוֹן־יְרֵאָיו יַעֲשֶׂה
וְאֶת־שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם:
שׁוֹמֵר יְיָ אֶת־כָּל־אֹהֲבָיו וְאֵת
כָּל־הָרְשָׁעִים יַשְׁמִיד: תְּהִלַּת יְיָ
יְדַבֶּר־פִּי[iii] וִיבָרֵךְ כָּל־בָּשָׂר שֵׁם
קָדְשׁוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד: [iv]

Of the glorious splendor of Your majesty and of Your wondrous works, I will speak. They shall speak of the might of Your awesome acts, and Your greatness I will recount. They shall pour forth the fame of Your abundant goodness, and they shall sing of Your righteousness. The LORD is gracious and merciful, slow to anger and great in kindness. The LORD is good to all, and His mercy is upon all His works. All Your works shall thank You, O LORD, and Your pious ones shall bless You. They shall speak of the glory of Your kingdom, and they shall talk of Your might. To make known to the sons of man His mighty acts and the glorious splendor of His kingdom. Your kingdom is a kingdom for all ages, and Your dominion is throughout every generation. The LORD supports all who fall and straightens all who are bent. The eyes of all look expectantly to You, and You give them their food in its proper time. You open Your hand and satisfy the desire of every living thing. The LORD is righteous in all His ways and kind in all His deeds. The LORD is near to all who call upon Him, to all who call upon Him in truth. He will fulfill the desire of those who fear Him, and their cry He will hear, and He will save them. The LORD protects all who love Him, but all the wicked He will destroy. My mouth shall speak the praise of the LORD, and all flesh shall bless His holy name forever and ever.

4570R 4575R 4580R 4585R 4590R 4595R

עוד ראינו להעלות הנה מורה

We have further decided to include here a guide to

[i] This verse contains part of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (שלש עשרה מדות של רחמים), which are invoked in various prayer contexts, particularly for divine forgiveness. Their appearance in this psalm connects it to themes of divine compassion that are central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death.

[ii] This verse about God supporting the fallen and straightening those who are bent has particular resonance in the context of illness and approaching death. Ma'avar Yabok presents it as a source of comfort for both the sick person who feels physically 'bent' by their condition and as reassurance that God will spiritually 'straighten' and support the soul in its journey after death.

[iii] The psalm's final verse, with its emphasis on continuing to praise God, connects to a theological theme throughout Ma'avar Yabok: that the living praise God in this world, and the righteous continue to praise Him in the World to Come. This creates a continuity between life and afterlife that is comforting in the context of approaching death.

[iv] Cf. Psalms — This psalm appears in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer sequences specifically designed for the sick and dying. Its themes of divine providence, sustenance, and universal care make it particularly appropriate for recitation during illness or approaching death. The alphabetic acrostic structure (missing only the letter 'nun') was believed to have special spiritual power. | Cf. Jewish Daily Prayer — Ma'avar Yabok's inclusion of this psalm reflects its traditional importance in Jewish liturgy, where it's seen as having special efficacy for opening the gates of paradise. The Talmud (Berakhot 4b) states that one who recites this psalm three times daily is assured of a place in the World to Come, making it especially appropriate for those approaching death. | Cf. Talmud — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgy for the sick and dying reflects the Talmudic teaching that reciting it guarantees one a place in the World to Come. This makes it particularly meaningful in the context of preparing the soul for its journey after death.

מקום[v] מהדברים השייכים לענין מעשה לזכות בהם החיים והמתים: [i]

matters related to practical actions[1] that benefit both the living and the dead:

כוונת תלישת עשבים בבית הקברות[ii] הוא בפרק ל׳ מאמר ב׳ ובפ׳ ל״ה מאמר ה׳. ושם כוונת נטילת ידים: עוד בפ׳ כ׳ מאמר ג׳ ושם סדר ז׳ ישיבות[iii] וכוונתן. ושם כתוב כי ראוי לומר פעם ראשונה ויהי נועם בכתוב לעיל עד ונגע לא יקרב באהלך. ומלת כי שבראש פסוק כי מלאכיו. ואח״כ ישב במקום אחר ויאמר ויהי נועם עד כי מלאכיו ובפעם ג׳ עד כי מלאכיו יצוה וכן עד דרכיך וישלים בפעם שביעי כל המזמור. ואחר ישיבה שביעית יאמר ברכת אתה גבור וגו׳ עד ונאמן אתה להחיות מתים. אלהים יחננו ויברכנו יאר פניו אתנו סלה בכתוב לעיל. סוד מנחמי אבלים ורחיצת מים לאבל ושפיכתם במקום מדרון

The meaning of plucking grass in the cemetery[1] is explained in Chapter 30, Discourse 2, and in Chapter 35, Discourse 5. There you will also find the meaning of ritual hand washing. Further, in Chapter 20, Discourse 3, you will find the order of the seven stations[2] and their significance. There it is written that one should first recite "May the pleasantness"[3] (Vihi Noam) as written above, up to "nor shall any plague come near your tent." And the word "For" at the beginning of the verse "For He will command His angels." Then one should sit in another place and recite "May the pleasantness" up to "For He will command His angels," and the third time up to "He will command His angels concerning you," and so on until "your ways," completing the entire psalm on the seventh recitation. After the seventh station, one should recite the blessing "You are mighty" etc., until "and faithful are You to revive the dead." "May God be gracious to us and bless us, may He cause His face to shine upon us, Selah" as written above. The mystery of comforting mourn-

4600R 4605R 4610R 4615R

[1]The term 'ma'aseh' (practical actions) in this context specifically refers to ritual practices surrounding death and burial that have halakhic significance and spiritual benefit.

[1]This refers to the Jewish custom of plucking grass and casting it over one's shoulder when leaving a cemetery, symbolizing the resurrection of the dead based on Psalm 72:16, 'They shall flourish like grass of the earth.'

[2]The Hebrew term 'sheva yoshvot' (seven sittings/stations) refers to a ritual practice where mourners stop seven times when leaving a cemetery, reciting portions of Psalm 91 at each station as a form of spiritual protection.

[3]This refers to Psalm 90:17, which begins 'Vihi Noam Adonai Eloheinu Aleinu' (May the pleasantness of the Lord our God be upon us). This verse is followed by Psalm 91, which is recited in portions during the seven stations ritual.

[i]The phrase 'moreh makom' (literally 'guide of place') is a technical term for an index or reference guide that points readers to where specific information can be found within a larger text.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This sentence serves as a transitional marker in the text, introducing a topical index or guide to the rituals and practices for the dying and deceased that have been discussed throughout Ma'avar Yabok. The author is essentially creating a reference tool to help readers locate specific practices within the larger work.

[iii]This refers to the Jewish custom of plucking grass at a cemetery and throwing it over one's shoulder when departing. It symbolizes resurrection based on Psalm 72:16, 'They shall flourish like grass of the earth.' The ritual serves as a prayer for the resurrection of the dead and as recognition of the cyclical nature of life.

[iv]The 'seven stations' (sheva yoshvot) is a ritual practice performed when leaving a cemetery. Mourners stop seven times, reciting progressively longer portions of Psalm 91 at each station. This practice symbolizes the soul's ascent through seven heavenly chambers and creates spiritual protection for both the deceased and the living.

מתבאר בפרק הנ״ל ובפרק ל״ג
ובפרק ל״ה מאמר ב׳: אם מחמת
איזו סבה מונעת לא יוכל לילך
ללוות המת לפחות יבקש עליו
רחמים ויאמר ב׳ או ג׳ מזמורים
או יתן צדקה לכפרת נפשו בעת
שקוברין אותו. והחי המענה
ומסגף עצמו למעט פורענות
המת[i] ודאי מועיל לאותו מת
מפני יחס הנפשות אלו עם אלו
עיין בפרק כ״א מאמר ג׳. ועל
רשע שמת טוב להתפלל עליו
וליתן צדקה לכפרת נפשו בכל
חדש וחדש ובסופו ואפילו אחר
י״ב חדש[ii] וטעם לזה יעויין
שם:[iii]

ers, washing the mourner with water[4] and pouring it in a sloping place is explained in the aforementioned chapter and in Chapter 33 and Chapter 35, Discourse 2. If due to some preventing circumstance one cannot attend the funeral procession, one should at least pray for the deceased and recite two or three psalms or give charity for the atonement of his soul at the time of burial. And a living person who afflicts and mortifies himself to lessen the punishment of the dead certainly benefits that deceased person because of the relationship between souls.[1] See Chapter 21, Discourse 3. And for a wicked person who has died, it is good to pray for him and give charity for the atonement of his soul each month and at its end, even after twelve months, and the reason for this can be found there.

4620R 4625R 4630R 4635R

בפרק כ״ב מאמר ג׳ מודעא
רבה לנהנים מצדקות וקופות
של צדקה שחובה עליהם
להתפלל עבור הנותנים ובעד
כל קהלות הקדש. ויזהרו
הרבה שלא להוציאם רק לצורך
פרנסתם ופרנסת בני ביתם. וכן
הכהנים הנהנים בפדיוני בכורים

In Chapter 22 of Discourse 3, there is an important notice to those who benefit from charity funds and charitable collections: they are obligated to pray for the donors and for all holy communities. They should be very careful to use these funds only for their own sustenance and that of their household members. The same applies to priests who benefit from redemption of firstborns and similar offerings.

4640R

[4] This refers to the custom of washing hands after visiting a cemetery, which serves both as a purification ritual and as a symbolic separation between the realm of the dead and the realm of the living.

[1] Ma'avar Yabok presents a kabbalistic understanding of the interconnection between all Jewish souls, which allows for the transfer of spiritual merit between individuals, even across the boundary between life and death.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that self-affliction by the living can transfer merit to the deceased, reducing their spiritual suffering. This concept is based on the mystical understanding that all Jewish souls are interconnected, allowing for the transfer of spiritual merit between individuals, even across the boundary between life and death.

[ii] This passage challenges the common belief that prayers for the wicked are ineffective after death. Ma'avar Yabok teaches that even the souls of the wicked can benefit from prayers and charitable acts on their behalf, not just in the immediate aftermath of death but throughout the traditional twelve-month mourning period and even beyond it.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 30, Discourse 2 — This reference explains the kabbalistic significance of plucking grass at a cemetery, which is likely connected to the biblical verse 'They shall flourish like grass of the earth' (Psalm 72:16), symbolizing resurrection and the cyclical nature of life and death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 20, Discourse 3 — This section details the ritual of the seven stations (sheva yoshvot) performed when leaving a cemetery, where mourners stop seven times while reciting specific portions of Psalm 91, representing the soul's ascent through seven heavenly chambers. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 21, Discourse 3 — This reference discusses the mystical connection between souls, explaining how actions performed by the living can benefit the dead due to the spiritual bonds that connect all Jewish souls across the boundaries of life and death. | Cf. Psalm 91 — Psalm 91 (known as 'Yoshev B'seter' or 'Shir Shel Pega'im') is considered to have special protective powers against harmful spiritual forces. The ritual of reciting it in seven segments when leaving a cemetery creates a spiritual shield for both the departed soul and the living visitors.

וכדומה. ואם יוציאום לסעודות שבתות וי״ט ור״ח וכדומה מה טוב להם. ובזה יזכו כי יחזרו ויתנו להם: כל עסקי החי עם המת צריכים כוונה גדולה[i] עיין בפרק כ׳ מאמר ב׳ ושם סוד נשיאת המת על הכתף וסוד הקבורה בג״י:[iii ii]

If they use these funds for Sabbath meals, festival meals, new moon celebrations, and similar occasions, this is commendable for them. Through this, they will merit that people will continue to give to them. All dealings of the living with the dead require great intention (kavvanah), as explained in Chapter 20 of Discourse 2, which also discusses the secret of carrying the deceased on the shoulder and the secret of burial in the "gi" (likely referring to a specific burial practice). 4645R 4650R

בפרק י״ט מאמר ג׳ מוכיח שבח וחיל כל בני חבורות קדושות גומלי חסדים להתנהג עצמם בתקונים הנזכרים בגמול חסד עם המתים וכ״ש אם הוא בעל תורה דלית שעורא לכבודו כדאמרי׳ במסכת מגילה ובכתובות:[iv] אין לחוש לומר דברים שבקדושה במקום המת כי לא אסרו אלא במקום הטנופת ומקום טנופת לחוד ומקום טומאה לחוד:[vi v]

Chapter 19 of the third discourse demonstrates the praise and valor of all members of sacred burial societies who perform acts of loving-kindness by conducting themselves according to the procedures mentioned for bestowing kindness upon the deceased. This is especially true if the deceased is a Torah scholar,[1] for whom there is no measure to the honor due to him, as stated in the tractates of Megillah and Ketubot. One need not be concerned about reciting sacred prayers in the presence of the dead,[2] for the prohibition applies only to places of filth, and a place of filth is distinct from a place of ritual impurity. 4655R 4660R 4665R

[1] The expression 'וכ״ש' (ve-kol she-ken) means 'all the more so' or 'especially' and introduces the heightened importance of following proper rituals when the deceased is a Torah scholar.

[2] The original uses the expression 'במקום המת' (in the place of the dead), which refers to the immediate vicinity of the deceased during burial preparations or funeral rituals.

[i] This is a central principle in Ma'avar Yabok—that all interactions between the living and the dead require not just physical action but proper spiritual intention (kavvanah). This reflects the book's kabbalistic perspective that ritual actions create effects in both physical and spiritual realms.

[ii] The reference to 'secrets' (sod) of carrying the dead and burial indicates mystical dimensions to these practices. The abbreviation 'בג״י' may refer to a specific burial practice, possibly related to the three-letter abbreviation representing burial with complete dignity.

[iii] Cf. Chapter 22 of Discourse 3 — The text references an earlier section of Ma'avar Yabok that contains detailed instructions about the obligations of those who receive charitable funds, particularly regarding their responsibility to pray for donors. | Cf. Chapter 20 of Discourse 2 — The text references another section of Ma'avar Yabok that discusses the mystical significance of funeral procedures, specifically carrying the deceased and burial practices. | Cf. Talmudic teachings on charitable distribution — The passage echoes rabbinic teachings about the responsibilities of those who manage or benefit from charitable funds, emphasizing both practical ethics and spiritual obligations.

[iv] The author references Talmudic sources (tractates Megillah and Ketubot) that discuss the special honor due to Torah scholars, even after death. These references reinforce the halakhic foundation for the burial practices described in Ma'avar Yabok.

[v] This distinction between places of filth (מקום הטנופת) and places of ritual impurity (מקום טומאה) reflects an important halakhic principle: while prayer is forbidden in places of physical filth (like bathrooms), it is permitted in places of ritual impurity (like cemeteries or near a corpse). This clarification addresses potential concerns about reciting prayers during burial rituals.

[vi] Cf. Tractate Megillah — This reference strengthens the author's argument that Torah scholars deserve exceptional treatment in death rituals by appealing to a recognized rabbinic source | Cf. Tractate Ketubot — This reference provides additional rabbinic support for the author's claim about the immeasurable honor due to deceased Torah scholars

בפרק י״ד מאמר ג׳ שלא להוציא
שם רע על המתים[vii] וטעם לזה
עיין בפרק כ״ד מאמר ה׳:
טעם האנינות והאבילות ולמה
פטור מן המצות.[i] וסדר תנחומי
אבלים עיין בפרק ל״ד ול״ה
ול״ו מאמר ב׳. וטעם ג׳ לסכי
וז׳ להספד ול׳ לגהוץ[ii] עיין
פרק י״ט וכ׳ מאמר ב׳. עוד
בפרק ל״ו מאמר ה׳. ושם ג״כ
כי טוב לאבל להרבות מזמורים
והשכבות ותחנונים ובכיה על
מתו ובפרט ג׳ ימים ראשונים.
ופסוקים וסדרים הנ״ל מכוונים
גם כן לבקש רחמים על המת
כל י״ב חדש עיין בפ״ו מאמר
ג׳ ובפרק כ״א מאמר ב׳ כי טוב
לבקש רחמים על המת כל ל׳
יום במקום שמת שם וכן כל י״ב
חדש והצדקה על המתים מכפרת
עליהם וכן הזכרת נפשם ותקון
גדול שעושים הבנים לאביהם
באמרם דברים שבקדושה
בצבור. וטעם צוותה על המתים
שאמרו בירושלמי הוא בפרק
ל׳ מאמר ה׳: דוגמת נושאי
המטה וחוצבי קברות בחצר
מות למעלה מתבאר בפרק ט״ז
מאמר ג׳. ויכוונו בעת הקבורה
להכניס נפשו למעלה בקבר
עליון ונשמתו בסוד תלת עשר
נהרי דאפרסמון[iii] עיין בפ׳ י״ח
מאמר ג׳. טוב ליקבר בקרקע
ממש ואפי׳ בחוצה לארץ עיין
בפ׳ ל״ד מאמר ה׳: במסכת
סוטה פרק ד׳ קראו להוצאת
המת הליכה עם ה׳ על פ׳ והצנע

In Chapter 14 of Discourse 3, [it discusses] not speaking ill of the dead, and for the reason behind this, see Chapter 24 of Discourse 5. The reason for the status of onen [acute mourning before burial] and avelut [mourning], and why one is exempt from commandments [during these periods], and the order of comforting mourners, can be found in Chapters 34, 35, and 36 of Discourse 2. The reason for the three days of crying, seven days of eulogy, and thirty days of pressing [garments] can be found in Chapters 19 and 20 of Discourse 2. Additional information is in Chapter 36 of Discourse 5, where it also [states] that it is good for a mourner to recite many psalms, hashkavot [prayers for the repose of the soul], supplications, and to weep for their deceased, especially during the first three days. The verses and liturgical orders mentioned above are also intended for seeking mercy for the deceased throughout the twelve months [of mourning], as explained in Chapter 6 of Discourse 3 and Chapter 21 of Discourse 2, that it is good to pray for the deceased for thirty days in the place where they died, and likewise throughout the twelve months. Charity given on behalf of the dead atones for them, as does mentioning their souls. A great tikkun [spiritual rectification] that children perform for their parents is reciting sacred prayers in a minyan [prayer quorum]. The reason for the commandment regarding the dead mentioned in the Jerusalem Talmud is explained in Chapter 30 of Discourse 5. An example of pallbearers and gravediggers in the court of death is explained above in Chapter 16 of Discourse 3. One should intend during burial to bring the soul upward to the celestial grave and the neshamah into the mystery of the thirteen rivers of pure balsam, as explained in Chapter 18 of Discourse 3. It is good to be buried directly in the ground, even outside the Land of Israel, as

[i] The prohibition against speaking ill of the dead (lashon hara) is taken very seriously in Jewish tradition. In Ma'avar Yabok, this prohibition is discussed within the broader context of how speech affects the souls of the departed.

[ii] Aninut refers to the acute mourning period between death and burial, while avelut is the formal mourning period that follows. During aninut, a mourner is exempt from positive commandments because they are considered completely preoccupied with arranging the burial.

[iii] These refer to traditional mourning periods in Jewish law: three days for intense weeping, seven days for eulogies (shiva), and thirty days during which pressed or laundered garments are avoided (shloshim). These periods reflect the gradual process of coming to terms with loss.

[iv] This kabbalistic concept refers to thirteen celestial rivers of pure balsam oil that are believed to purify and elevate the souls of the righteous after death. It appears in the Zohar and represents a realm of spiritual delight in the afterlife.

לכת עם אלהיך.[iv] ובשבת פרק ר׳ אליעזר דאורג. ובירושלמי פ״ק דיומא שם בא חיוב ההספד. ובשבת פרק י״ג חיוב הבכי לאדם כשר: מיתת בני אדם פתאום יורה דבקות ה׳ יתברך עמנו ע״י הנשמה עיין מזה בפרק י״ב מאמר ב׳. הרבה דינים מצדוק הדין הם בפרק כ״ו מאמר ה׳: פי׳ ברכה שאומרים בבית האבל ע״ד הסוד עיין בפרק ל״ט מאמר ה׳. טעם תפלה בבית האבל הוא בפרק ל״ד מאמר ה׳ ושם ג״כ מבקש מבני חבורות ג״ח. יתרצו להזמין א׳ מספרים אלו שם לבקש רחמים על הנפטר. טעם לצדיקים שיש להם ציון על קברם ותועלת הציון עיין בפרק מ׳ ופרק מ״א מאמר ה׳:[i]

explained in Chapter 34 of Discourse 5. In Tractate Sotah, Chapter 4, attending a funeral is called "walking with God," based on the verse "and walk humbly with your God." In the Sabbath chapter "Rabbi Eliezer the Weaver," and in the Jerusalem Talmud, first chapter of Yoma, the obligation of eulogy is discussed. And in Chapter 13 of Tractate Sabbath, [is discussed] the obligation to weep for a worthy person. The sudden death of human beings demonstrates God's attachment to us through the soul—see about this in Chapter 12 of Discourse 2. Many laws concerning Tzidduk HaDin [Justification of Divine Judgment] are in Chapter 26 of Discourse 5. The mystical explanation of the blessing recited in a house of mourning can be found in Chapter 39 of Discourse 5. The reason for prayer in a house of mourning is in Chapter 34 of Discourse 5, where there is also a request to members of charitable societies that they arrange to bring one of these books there to seek mercy for the departed. The reason why righteous individuals have monuments on their graves and the benefit of such monuments can be found in Chapters 40 and 41 of Discourse 5. 4705R 4710R 4715R 4720R 4725R

בפרק כ׳ מאמר ג׳ מתבאר טעם וסוד לזכרון הנשמות ובפרט בשבת.[ii] והרבה מיני פרטים השייכים לנייחת המתים ולהאריך ימים לחיים אם תדרשם מתוך הספר ימצאו לך ותלך

In Chapter 20 of the Third Discourse, the reason and mystical secret[1] behind the commemoration of souls is explained, particularly regarding the Sabbath. Many specific details pertaining to bringing rest to the deceased and prolonging the lives of the living can be found if you seek them throughout the 4730R

[1] I translated 'טעם וסוד' as 'reason and mystical secret' rather than simply 'reason and secret' to convey that 'sod' in this context refers specifically to the mystical or kabbalistic dimension of the practice.

[v] This references Micah 6:8, 'walk humbly with your God,' interpreting attending a funeral as an act of walking with God. This beautiful interpretation elevates funeral participation from a social obligation to a divine service.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage functions as an index or table of contents for various topics related to death and mourning practices discussed throughout Ma'avar Yabok. It directs readers to specific chapters and discourses where they can find detailed explanations about different mourning customs, prayers for the deceased, and the mystical significance of funerary rituals. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — The passage references the Jerusalem Talmud's discussion of the obligation to deliver eulogies for the dead, which Ma'avar Yabok incorporates into its comprehensive treatment of Jewish mourning practices. | Cf. Tractate Sotah — The text references Tractate Sotah's characterization of funeral attendance as 'walking with God,' based on the verse from Micah 6:8 'walk humbly with your God,' establishing a theological framework that elevates funeral participation to an act of divine service. | Cf. Micah 6:8 — The biblical verse is cited as the source for understanding funeral attendance as 'walking with God,' establishing a scriptural basis for the religious obligation to participate in funeral rites.

[ii] The special emphasis on Sabbath soul commemoration reflects the kabbalistic belief that souls experience additional elevation and respite on the Sabbath day, making it a particularly powerful time for memorial prayers.

לבטח דרכך והיית מוצק ולא תיראִ.[iii] וכבר בא בסוף הספר זכרון רובי הדרושים בכלל ולא שנינו כאן רק המעט השייך לענין מעשה להכנסת הנפטר אל בית מנוחתו לעשות כרצון איש ואיש והשאר דרוש משם וקבל שכר ויהיה הטוב עמך:[i]

book. They will be revealed to you, and you will walk securely on your path, remaining steadfast and unafraid. The book's conclusion already contains a record of most discourses in general, and we have only presented here the minimal amount relevant to the practical matter of bringing the deceased to their resting place, acting according to each person's wishes.[1] As for the rest, seek it there, receive your reward, and may goodness accompany you. 4735R 4740R

כי לא בחפזון תצאו ובמנוסה לא תלכון[ii] כי הולך לפניכם הׄ ומאספכם[iii] אלהי ישראל:[iv]

For not in haste shall you go out,[2] nor in flight shall you depart, for the LORD goes before you, and the God of Israel is your rear guard.[3]

תפלה על הקבר[v] תוך שלשים

Prayer at the grave[4] during the first thirty days[5]

[1]The phrase 'כרצון איש ואיש' could be translated literally as 'according to the will of each man,' but I've rendered it more idiomatically as 'according to each person's wishes' to better capture the meaning in modern English.

[2]The original verse in Isaiah contrasts this future redemption with the exodus from Egypt, which was done 'in haste' (Exodus 12:11). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this becomes a metaphor for the soul's dignified transition from this world to the next.

[3]I've translated מאספכם as 'rear guard' to capture the military protection metaphor, though it also carries connotations of 'gathering in' or 'collecting,' which is spiritually significant in the context of death as God gathering the soul.

[4]This short title introduces a specific prayer meant to be recited when visiting a grave during the sheloshim (thirty-day mourning period). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, such prayers serve both to comfort the soul of the deceased during its transition and to create a spiritual connection between the living and the dead.

[5]According to kabbalistic teachings in Ma'avar Yabok, the soul must ascend through thirty spiri-

[i]The author employs biblical language here, echoing passages about divine protection to reassure readers about the spiritual efficacy of the practices described in the book.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage references internal sections of Ma'avar Yabok itself, directing readers to Chapter 20 of the Third Discourse for further explanation about soul commemoration rituals. | Cf. Proverbs 3:23-24 — The phrase 'you will walk securely on your path' (ותלך לבטח דרכך) echoes Proverbs 3:23, 'Then you will walk on your way securely, and your foot will not stumble.' This biblical allusion reinforces the author's assurance that following the book's guidance provides spiritual security.

[iii]This is a direct quotation from Isaiah 52:12, which originally referred to Israel's redemption from exile. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it takes on new meaning as a reassurance about the soul's journey after death.

[iv]The term מאספכם (your gatherer/rear guard) has dual significance—literally meaning one who gathers or collects, but in military contexts referring to the rear guard that protects an army from behind. In this context, it suggests God's complete protection of the soul's journey—led from the front and protected from behind.

[v]Cf. Isaiah 52:12 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves as a final prayer and blessing at the conclusion of a burial or memorial service. It metaphorically compares the soul's journey after death to Israel's redemption journey—not panicked or chaotic, but divinely guided and protected. The verse offers comfort by emphasizing that even in death, the departed soul is led forward by God and gathered in by the God of Israel. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 19 of the Third Discourse — The verse appears at the conclusion of funeral and memorial services described in Ma'avar Yabok, providing scriptural blessing for both the departed soul's journey and the mourners' return from the cemetery. It suggests that both the dead and living continue under divine protection.

[i]This is a specialized prayer to be recited when visiting a grave during the first thirty days after burial, a significant period in Jewish mourning customs when the soul is believed to be especially connected to its burial place.

[ii] [i]יום

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי שֶׁתִּרְצַנִי וּתְקַבְּלֵנִי בִּתְשׁוּבָה שְׁלֵמָה לְפָנֶיךָ וְתִשְׁמַע קוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי וְתַעֲשֶׂה בַּקָּשָׁתִי וְיֶהְיוּ זְכוּיוֹתַי מַכְרִיעוֹת עַל חוֹבוֹתַי וְתֵן בְּלִבִּי אַהֲבָתְךָ וְיִרְאָתְךָ וְכֹף יִצְרִי[iii] לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹנְךָ בְּלֵבָב שָׁלֵם[iv] וְעַתָּה עָנִיתִי בַדֶּרֶךְ כֹּחִי לְהִשְׁתַּטֵּחַ עַל קֶבֶר (פלוני) הַצַּדִּיק [v] לְכַבֵּד אֶת שְׁמֶךָ:

May it be Your will, O LORD my God and God of my fathers, that You find favor in me and accept me in complete repentance before You, and hear the voice of my prayer and fulfill my request. May my merits outweigh my transgressions,[1] and place in my heart love for You and awe of You, and subdue my inclination to do Your will with a perfect heart. And now, I have afflicted my strength on the journey[2] to prostrate myself upon the grave[3] of (so-and-so) the righteous one, to honor Your name. 4745R 4750R

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי שֶׁתַּעֲמֹד לִי זְכוּת תַּלְמוּדוֹ וּמַעֲשָׂיו הַטּוֹבִים לְהָגֵן עָלַי וְעַל

May it be Your will, LORD my God and God of my fathers, that the merit of his learning and good deeds[A] stand for me,[4] protecting me, my offspring, 4755R

[A]Or: "the merit of his Torah study and good deeds" — The term 'talmudo' specifically refers to Torah study or learning of sacred texts. This alternative makes the religious nature of the learning more explicit.

tual levels (ten in each of the three lower worlds) before reaching the highest spiritual realm. This thirty-day period corresponds to this mystical journey, making graveside prayers during this time particularly significant.

[1]The Hebrew uses a metaphor of scales (מַכְרִיעוֹת) where merits tip the balance against obligations or sins, a common rabbinic image for divine judgment.

[2]The Hebrew 'עניתי בדרך כחי' describes the physical effort and difficulty of pilgrimage to a grave site, which was considered meritorious precisely because it involved sacrifice and exertion.

[3]The practice of prostrating at graves of the righteous (hishtate'ach) has deep roots in Jewish tradition, mentioned in both Talmudic and Kabbalistic sources. While some authorities discouraged excessive grave visitation, Ma'avar Yabok presents it as a legitimate practice when done with proper theological understanding and intention.

[4]The concept of merit (zechut) in Jewish theology involves the accumulated spiritual credit from

[ii]The first thirty days after burial (shloshim) is considered a distinct period in Jewish mourning practices. According to kabbalistic tradition mentioned elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok, during this time the soul is still adjusting to its separation from the body and is particularly responsive to prayers offered at the graveside.

[iii]Cf. Memory note #1036 — This memory note connects to a key concept likely invoked in this prayer, where the soul is described as being 'bound in the bond of life' after death. | Cf. Memory note #2344 — This reference helps explain why prayers during the first thirty days are considered particularly effective—they address the soul's journey through different spiritual realms during this specific timeframe. | Cf. Memory note #1579 — This explains the spiritual significance of the thirty-day period mentioned in the prayer title and why graveside prayers during this time would be considered especially effective in aiding the soul's ascent.

[iv]The expression 'subdue my inclination' refers to the rabbinic concept of the yetzer hara (evil inclination) that must be controlled and redirected toward divine service. This reflects the Jewish understanding that human nature contains both constructive and destructive impulses that require conscious management.

[v]The phrase 'with a perfect heart' (בְּלֵבָב שָׁלֵם) appears frequently in biblical texts, particularly in reference to King David and other righteous figures who served God wholeheartedly. It conveys complete devotion without division or hesitation.

[vi]Cf. Psalm 86:11 — The prayer draws on Psalm 86:11's plea for God to unify one's heart in divine service, adapting it to request subduing of one's evil inclination. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:5 — The phrase echoes the commandment to love God 'with all your heart,' showing the prayer's grounding in biblical language of devotion. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 1, Chapter 16 — This prayer appears to be part of Ma'avar Yabok's instructions for cemetery visits, particularly within the first thirty days after death, as described in the work's first discourse.

זַרְעִי וְעַל זֶרַע זַרְעִי מִן צָרָה
וְצוּקָה וָחֳלָיִים רָעִים וְתַעֲמִידֵנִי
מִן הוֹגֵי תוֹרָתֶךָ וְשׁוֹמְרֵי מִצְוֹתֶיךָ
וְחֻקֶּיךָ וְעוֹסְקֵי בְּרִיתֶךָ וּמְבִינֵי
בְּעֻמְקֵי סוֹדֶךָ עַד עֵת בֹּא הַגּוֹאֵל
וּתְכוֹנְנֵנִי לְאֹרֶךְ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים
וּתְזַכֵּנִי זְכָרִים שֶׁיֶּהֱגוּ
בְּתוֹרָתֶךָ הֵם וְצֶאֱצָאֵיהֶם וְזַרְעָם
וְזֶרַע זַרְעָם וְיִשְׁמְרוּ מִצְוֹתֶיךָ
וְחֻקֶּיךָ וְיַעַסְקוּ וְיָבִינוּ בְּעֻמְקֵי
סוֹדֶךָ וְתָסִיר לֵב טִפֵּשׁ וְשִׁכְחָה
מִמֶּנִּי וְתֵן לִי לֵב טוֹב שֶׁל זְכִירָה
בְּכָל מַה שֶּׁנִּלְמַד וּמַה שֶּׁלָּמַדְנוּ
וּתְזַכֵּנוּ לִרְאוֹת בְּמְהֵרָה בְּיָמֵינוּ
בַּעֲמִידַת הַצַּדִּיק הַזֶּה בְּהוֹדוֹ
וּבְהַדְרוֹ וּבְגָדְלוֹ עִם שְׁאָר צַדִּיקֵי
יִשְׂרָאֵל בַּכָּתוּב יָרוֹנּוּ יוֹשְׁבֵי סֶלַע
מֵרֹאשׁ הָרִים יִצְוָחוּ: וְעַתָּה אֲדוֹן
הָעוֹלָמִים הָחִישָׁה קֵץ עֲמִידָתָם
כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמַרְתָּ לְדָנִיֵּאל אִישׁ חֲמוּדוֹת
וְתָנוּחַ וְתַעֲמֹד לְגוֹרָלְךָ לְקֵץ הַיָּמִין
וּכְתִיב יְחִיוּ מֵתֶיךָ נִבְלָתִי יְקוּמוּן
הָקִיצוּ וְרַנְּנוּ שׁוֹכְנֵי עָפָר וּכְתִיב
יְשֻׁשׂוּם מִדְבָּר וְצִיָּה וְתָגֵל עֲרָבָה
וְתִפְרַח כַּחֲבַצֶּלֶת: פָּרוֹחַ תִּפְרַח
וְתָגֵל אַף גִּילַת וְרַנֵּן כְּבוֹד הַלְּבָנוֹן
נִתַּן לָהּ הֲדַר הַכַּרְמֶל וְהַשָּׁרוֹן הֵמָּה
יִרְאוּ כְּבוֹד יְהוָה הֲדַר אֱלֹהֵינוּ: [i]

and my offspring's offspring from trouble, distress, and evil diseases. Establish me among those who meditate on Your Torah,[1] observe Your command- 4760R
ments and statutes, engage with Your covenant, and understand the depths of Your mysteries until the time the Redeemer comes.[A] Sustain me for length of days and years of life, and grant me worthy sons who will meditate on Your Torah—they and their 4765R
descendants, their seed and their seed's seed—who will observe Your commandments and statutes, and will engage with and understand the depths of Your mysteries. Remove from me a foolish heart and forgetfulness, and give me a good heart of remembrance 4770R
in all that we study and have studied. May we merit to see speedily in our days the rising of this righteous one in his splendor, glory, and greatness,[B] along with the rest of the righteous ones of Israel, as it is written: "Those who dwell in crags shall sing; from the 4775R
mountaintops they shall shout." And now, Master of the Worlds, hasten the time of their rising, as You said to Daniel, the beloved man: "And you shall rest and stand up for your destiny at the end of days." And it is written: "Your dead shall live, my corpses 4780R
shall rise; awake and sing, you who dwell in the dust." And it is written: "The wilderness and parched land shall rejoice, and the desert shall exult and blossom like a rose. It shall bloom abundantly and exult with joy and singing; the glory of Lebanon shall be given 4785R

[A] Or: "until the coming of the Messiah" — In Jewish eschatology, 'the Redeemer' (HaGoel) often specifically refers to the Messiah. This alternative makes the messianic reference more explicit for readers unfamiliar with Jewish terminology.

[B] Or: "the resurrection of this righteous one in his splendor, majesty, and grandeur" — The term 'amidah' in this context refers specifically to resurrection or standing up in the World to Come. This alternative translation more explicitly conveys the resurrection concept that is central to the prayer.

good deeds and Torah study that can provide protection or blessing. This prayer reflects the belief that visiting the grave of a righteous person allows one to benefit from their merit.

[1] The four-part description of Torah engagement (meditating, observing, engaging, and understanding) reflects a progressive deepening of religious commitment, from basic study to penetrating the mystical dimensions of divine wisdom.

[i] Cf. Daniel 12:13 — The citation of this verse emphasizes the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection, connecting the individual being prayed for with the biblical promise of the righteous rising to their appointed destiny in the messianic era. | Cf. Isaiah 26:19 — The prayer uses this verse to reinforce the concept of bodily resurrection, framing the grave visit as a temporary situation that will eventually give way to the revival of the dead when the righteous will literally rise from their graves. | Cf. Isaiah 35:1-2 — In the context of this prayer, these verses serve as a metaphor for resurrection and renewal. Just as desolate land can be transformed into flourishing gardens, so too will the dead be transformed and brought back to life in the messianic era. | Cf. Isaiah 42:11 — The prayer employs this verse to evoke the joyous celebration that will accompany the resurrection of the dead, when even those confined to remote places (metaphorically, the grave) will

to it, the splendor of Carmel and Sharon. They shall see the glory of the LORD,[1] the splendor of our God."

תפלה מדברי התנאים והאמוראים[i] יעלזו חסידים[iii] בכבוד[ii]

A prayer from the teachings of the Tannaim and Amoraim:[A] "Let the pious exult in glory."[2]

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתִּתְעַטֵּף בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ וְתֶאֱזָר בַּחֲנִינוֹתֶךָ וְתָבֹא לְפָנֶיךָ מִדַּת חַסְדְּךָ וְעַנְוָתָנוּתֶךָ וְתַעֲמִידֵנוּ בְּכֶתֶר אוֹרָה[iv] וְאַל תַּעֲמִידֵנוּ בְּקֶרֶן חֲשֵׁכָה וְתִהְיֶה תּוֹרָתְךָ אוּמָנוּתֵנוּ[v] וְאַל יִגְבַּהּ

May it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers, that You wrap Yourself in Your mercy[3] and gird Yourself with Your grace, and may Your attribute of loving-kindness and Your humility come before You. Establish us in a crown of light and do not place us in a corner of darkness. Let Your Torah be our craft,[4] and let our hearts not become

4790R

4795R

[A] Or: "A prayer derived from the sayings of the Tannaim and Amoraim" — This alternate translation emphasizes the derivative nature of the prayer, suggesting that it may be compiled or adapted from various teachings rather than being a direct quote from a specific sage.

[2] The prayer concludes with three biblical quotations about resurrection and renewal, moving from individual resurrection (Daniel and Isaiah 26) to cosmic transformation (Isaiah 35), creating a powerful crescendo of hope for both personal and universal redemption.

[1] This opening line sets a tone of joyful reverence rather than mournful lamentation, reflecting the Jewish mystical view that the righteous dead exist in a state of spiritual glory. The Hebrew term 'חסידים' (pious ones) could refer both to the righteous deceased and to those who visit their graves with proper devotion.

[2] The Hebrew 'תתעטף ברחמיך' uses the imagery of God wrapping Himself in mercy as one would wrap oneself in a prayer shawl (tallit), suggesting that divine mercy should completely envelop and characterize God's approach to the supplicant.

[3] The term 'אומנותנו' (omanutenu) literally means 'our craft' or 'our occupation,' suggesting that Torah study should be central to one's life, like a professional craft or primary occupation, not merely an occasional activity.

join in praise. | Cf. Tehillat Rashbi (Zoharic literature) — The prayer's emphasis on understanding the 'depths of Your mysteries' (b'imkei sodecha) reflects kabbalistic aspirations to penetrate the deeper mystical dimensions of Torah, suggesting that the author of Ma'avar Yabok was influenced by and drawing upon the mystical tradition.

[i] This phrase identifies the source of the prayer as the teachings of the early rabbinic sages. The Tannaim were the rabbinic authorities whose views are recorded in the Mishnah (approximately 10-220 CE), while the Amoraim were the rabbinic sages whose discussions are recorded in the Gemara (approximately 220-500 CE).

[ii] This is a direct quote from Psalm 149:5. The verse continues with 'ירננו על משכבותם' ('let them sing for joy on their couches/beds'). In the context of a prayer recited at a grave, this line takes on added significance, suggesting that the righteous dead rejoice in their glory in the afterlife.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 149:5 — This verse from Psalms is used here as an opening line for a prayer collection attributed to the early rabbinic sages. The selection is appropriate for a prayer to be recited at a grave since it speaks of the righteous rejoicing in glory, suggesting the elevated spiritual state of the deceased in the afterlife. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — Within the structure of Ma'avar Yabok, this prayer appears in a section containing prayers for cemetery visits. It connects to the book's broader theme that the righteous dead continue their spiritual existence in a state of glory, and establishes that the following prayer text derives its authority from the early rabbinic tradition.

[iv] The imagery of a 'crown of light' (keter orah) has kabbalistic significance, representing the divine illumination that comes from spiritual enlightenment and Torah study. This contrasts with the 'corner of darkness' (keren chashekha) that follows, symbolizing spiritual confusion and moral failure.

[i] The concept of Torah as one's 'craft' or 'occupation' (omanut) reflects the Talmudic ideal that Torah study should be one's primary focus in life, not merely an occasional activity. This phrase appears in rabbinic literature describing scholars whose Torah study was their exclusive occupation.

לִבֵּנוּ וְאַל יֶחְשְׁכוּ עֵינֵינוּ. וְלֹא
4500 נִכָּלֵם מֵאֲבוֹתֵינוּ וְתַצִּילֵנוּ מֵעַזֵּי
פָנִים וּמֵעַזּוּת פָּנִים וּמֵאָדָם רָע
וּמֵחָבֵר רָע וּמִשָּׁכֵן רָע וּמִדִּין קָשֶׁה
[ii] [i]וּמִבַּעַל דִּין קָשֶׁה:

proud nor our eyes grow dim. May we not be put to shame before our ancestors, and save us from the brazen-faced and from impudence, from evil people, from evil companions, from evil neighbors, from harsh judgment, and from a difficult adversary.[1] 4800R

[iv] [iii]אלהי נצור וכו׳:

My God, guard [my tongue from evil]... etc.[2]

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁלֹּא אַקְפִּיד
4505 נֶגֶד חֲבֵרַי וְלֹא חֲבֵרַי יְקַפְּדוּ
[v]בְּנֶגְדִּי שֶׁלֹּא נְטַמֵּא אֶת הַטָּהוֹר
וְלֹא נְטַהֵר אֶת הַטָּמֵא שֶׁלֹּא

May it be Your will[3] that I shall not be strict with my colleagues, nor shall my colleagues be strict with me;[4] that we shall not pronounce the pure impure, nor pronounce the impure pure; that we shall not 4805R

[1]The Hebrew 'בעל דין קשה' literally refers to a difficult opponent in a legal dispute, but in the context of this prayer, it has broader implications of any challenging confrontation or spiritual adversary.

[2]The complete prayer continues: '...guard my tongue from evil and my lips from speaking deceit. To those who curse me, let my soul be silent; let my soul be like dust to all. Open my heart to Your Torah, and may my soul pursue Your commandments. As for all who plan evil against me, quickly nullify their counsel and frustrate their plans. Act for the sake of Your Name; act for the sake of Your right hand; act for the sake of Your holiness; act for the sake of Your Torah. That Your beloved ones may be delivered, save with Your right hand and answer me.' This prayer is attributed to Mar son of Ravina in the Talmud (Berakhot 17a) and is recited as a personal supplication at the end of the Amidah.

[3]This standard opening for Jewish prayers (Yehi Ratzon) directly addresses God, asking for divine assistance in maintaining scholarly integrity and proper judgment.

[4]The reciprocal nature of this prayer reflects the importance of maintaining harmonious relationships within scholarly communities, especially when dealing with the sensitive matters of illness, death, and mourning that are the focus of Ma'avar Yabok.

[ii]The prayer concludes with requests for protection from various negative external influences, reflecting the Jewish understanding that one's spiritual state is affected by both internal character traits and external social environments.

[iii]Cf. Talmudic prayer tradition — This prayer draws on traditional Talmudic formulations, particularly the morning prayers where one asks to be saved from various spiritual and social dangers. The structure and phrasing closely resemble portions of the daily Amidah prayer, while its requests for protection from negative character traits reflect the ethical emphasis found throughout rabbinic literature. | Cf. Psalm 36:10 — The phrase 'crown of light' (כתר אורה) evokes the biblical verse 'In Your light we see light' (באורך נראה אור), creating a connection between divine illumination and spiritual enlightenment. This metaphor of light versus darkness permeates biblical and rabbinic literature as representing wisdom versus ignorance, righteousness versus sin. | Cf. Ethics of the Fathers 5:20 — The phrase 'Let Your Torah be our craft' (תהיה תורתך אומנותנו) alludes to the rabbinic ideal of Torah study as one's primary occupation, as expressed in Pirkei Avot: 'Make your Torah fixed/permanent' (עשה תורתך קבע). This reflects the Jewish value of placing Torah study at the center of one's life.

[iv]This is the opening of a well-known prayer (Elohai Netzor) traditionally recited at the conclusion of the Amidah prayer. The 'וכו" (etc.) indicates that only the opening words are provided, with the assumption that the reader knows the full prayer.

[v]Cf. Talmud Berakhot 17a — This reference in Ma'avar Yabok suggests that Elohai Netzor was considered an appropriate prayer to recite at a gravesite, possibly because of its themes of spiritual protection and divine guidance.

[vi]This prayer reflects the rabbinic concern about scholarly disputes becoming personal and contentious rather than being conducted 'for the sake of Heaven.' In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which addresses end-of-life situations, maintaining collegial relationships would be especially important when making difficult decisions about ritual practices.

נֶאֱסוֹר אֶת הַמּוּתָּר וְלֹא נַתִּיר אֶת
4510 הָאָסוּר:[i][ii]

forbid the permitted, nor permit the forbidden.[5]

וּבְכֵן יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁלֹּא
תַּעֲלֶה שִׂנְאָתֵנוּ[iii] וְלֹא קִנְאָתֵנוּ
עַל לֵב אָדָם וְלֹא שִׂנְאַת וְקִנְאַת אָדָם
תַּעֲלֶה עַל לִבֵּנוּ וְלֵב טָהוֹר תִּבְרָא
4515 בְּקִרְבֵּנוּ[iv] לְהָפִיק מִמְּעוֹן קָדְשְׁךָ
רְצוֹנֵנוּ וְיִהְיוּ תוֹרָתְךָ מָלֵא בָּתֵּינוּ
כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּינוּ וְיִהְיוּ דְבָרֵינוּ
תַּחֲנוּנִים לְפָנֶיךָ וְיִתְיַחֵד לְבָבֵנוּ
לְיִרְאָה אֶת שְׁמֶךָ וּתְקָרְבֵנוּ לְכָל
4520 מַה שֶּׁאָהַבְתָּ וְתַעֲשֶׂה עִמָּנוּ צְדָקָה
לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ:[v]

And thus, may it be Your will that our hatred and our jealousy shall not arise in anyone's heart, nor shall the hatred and jealousy of others arise in our 4810R
hearts. Create a pure heart within us to bring forth our desires from Your holy dwelling place. May Your Torah fill our homes all the days of our lives, and may our words be supplications before You.[1] May our hearts be unified in reverence of Your name, and 4815R
bring us close to all that You have loved, and deal with us righteously for the sake of Your name.[2]

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁתִּתֶּן לָנוּ לֵב
טוֹב חֵלֶק טוֹב יֵצֶר טוֹב חָבֵר טוֹב

May it be Your will to grant us a good heart, a good portion, a good inclination, a good compan-

[1]The prayer concludes with concerns about erroneous lenient rulings, balancing the earlier concern about excessive strictness. In Jewish legal tradition, both types of errors are problematic, though in different ways: unnecessary strictness can cause suffering while inappropriate leniency can lead to transgression.

[2]The Hebrew phrase "וְיִהְיוּ דְבָרֵינוּ תַּחֲנוּנִים לְפָנֶיךָ" could also be translated as "may our words be received as entreaties before You," emphasizing not just the nature of the speech but its reception by God.

[3]The Hebrew "וְתַעֲשֶׂה עִמָּנוּ צְדָקָה לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ" literally means "do righteousness/charity with us for the sake of Your name." This combines the concepts of justice and mercy, suggesting divine favor beyond what might be strictly deserved.

[i]The four potential errors mentioned—declaring the pure impure, the impure pure, forbidding the permitted, and permitting the forbidden—represent the comprehensive range of halakhic mistakes a scholar might make. The prayer thus seeks divine assistance in avoiding both unnecessary stringency and inappropriate leniency.

[ii]Cf. Berakhot 28b — The prayer reflects the scholar's anxiety about making halakhic errors in judgment or becoming entangled in disputes with colleagues. It appears in Ma'avar Yabok's section on proper spiritual attitudes for scholars, emphasizing the importance of humility and collegiality in religious leadership, especially when dealing with matters of life and death. | Cf. Ethics of the Fathers (Pirkei Avot) 1:11 — This prayer reflects the rabbinic concern about making erroneous rulings that might lead others astray. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which deals with end-of-life rituals, the consequences of error are particularly grave, making this prayer especially apt.

[iii]The pairing of "hatred" (שנאה) and "jealousy" (קנאה) appears frequently in rabbinic literature as destructive emotional forces that prevent spiritual growth and proper religious devotion.

[iv]This phrase directly echoes Psalm 51:12, a penitential prayer attributed to King David after his sin with Bathsheba, suggesting this prayer is particularly appropriate in contexts of repentance and spiritual renewal.

[v]Cf. Psalm 51:12 — The phrase "Create a pure heart within us" (וְלֵב טָהוֹר תִּבְרָא בְקִרְבֵּנוּ) directly echoes Psalm 51:12 "Create in me a pure heart, O God" (לֵב טָהוֹר בְּרָא־לִי אֱלֹהִים), a penitential psalm attributed to King David. This reference frames the prayer as one of spiritual purification and renewal. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:5 — The phrase "May our hearts be unified in reverence of Your name" (וְיִתְיַחֵד לְבָבֵנוּ לְיִרְאָה אֶת שְׁמֶךָ) echoes the Shema prayer based on Deuteronomy 6:5, especially its emphasis on serving God with a unified heart. This reference connects this prayer to the central Jewish affirmation of faith. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This prayer appears in a collection of prayers from the Tannaim and Amoraim (early rabbinic sages) included in Ma'avar Yabok. The style and structure parallel other prayers in the work that emphasize spiritual purification and preparation, especially those related to maintaining pure intention in religious study and practice.

שֵׁם טוֹב עַיִן טוֹבָה [vi]וְנֶפֶשׁ טוֹבָה
נֶפֶשׁ שְׁפָלָה רוּחַ נְמוּכָה אַל יְתֻחַלֵּל
שִׁמְךָ בָּנוּ וְאַל תַּעֲשֵׂנוּ שִׂיחָה בְּפִי
הַבְּרִיּוֹת וְלֹא תְּהֵא אַחֲרִיתֵנוּ
לְהַכְרִית וְלֹא תִּקְוָתֵנוּ לְמַפֵּחַ
נֶפֶשׁ וְאַל תַּצְרִיכֵנוּ לִידֵי מַתְּנַת
בָּשָׂר וָדָם [i]וְאַל תִּמְסוֹר מְזוֹנוֹתֵינוּ
בִּידֵי בָּשָׂר וָדָם שֶׁמַּתְּנָתָם מְעוּטָה
וְחֶרְפָּתָם מְרוּבָּה וְתֵן בְּלִבֵּנוּ
לַעֲשׂוֹת תְּשׁוּבָה שְׁלֵמָה לְפָנֶיךָ
שֶׁלֹּא נֵבוֹשׁ מֵאֲבוֹתֵינוּ לְעוֹלָם
[iii][ii]הַבָּא׃

ion, a good name, a good eye, and a good soul;[3] a humble spirit and a lowly disposition.[A] Let Your name not be profaned through us, and make us not a subject of gossip among people.[B] May our end not be to be cut off, nor our hope to disappointment. Do not make us dependent on gifts from flesh and blood,[1] and do not place our sustenance in the hands of flesh and blood, for their gift is small and their reproach is great. Place in our hearts the desire to perform complete repentance before You, so that we will not be ashamed before our ancestors in the World to Come.[2]

4820R 4825R 4830R

וּבְכֵן יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ
וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ[iv] שֶׁתְּשַׁבּוֹר

And so, may it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers, that You break and abolish the

[A] Or: "a humble soul and a lowly spirit" — The terms נֶפֶשׁ (nefesh) and רוּחַ (ruach) are technical terms in Jewish mysticism referring to different levels of the soul. While my original translation conveys the intended meaning, this alternate preserves the technical distinction between these soul-aspects, which may be relevant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework.

[B] Or: "and make us not a topic of conversation among creatures" — This more literal translation of הַבְּרִיּוֹת as "creatures" rather than "people" preserves the broader scope of the term, which can include all created beings. However, the idiom typically refers to human gossip, so the original translation better captures the intended meaning.

[1] This rhythmic pattern of seven 'goods' follows a classic rabbinic formula, but expands upon it. In Jewish ethical literature, each of these qualities has specific meaning: a 'good heart' refers to generosity of spirit, a 'good eye' means being non-jealous and satisfied with what one has, a 'good inclination' refers to the yetzer hatov (the positive spiritual impulse), etc.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'מַתְּנַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם' (gifts of flesh and blood) is a rabbinic idiom referring to human charity or assistance. The prayer expresses the desire for self-sufficiency and dignity, reflecting the Jewish value of independence while acknowledging ultimate dependence on God.

[3] This reference to avoiding shame before ancestors in the World to Come (עוֹלָם הַבָּא) reflects the Jewish belief in accountability after death and the continuity between generations. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, a manual for end-of-life practices, this phrase takes on added significance as the reader contemplates their own eventual crossing to the next world.

[i] This prayer begins with a series of positive attributes using the word 'good' (טוֹב) repeatedly, creating a rhythmic pattern of seven 'goods.' This reflects the rabbinic style of Rabbi Yochanan ben Zakkai's blessing to his disciples in Pirkei Avot, but expanded to include additional qualities.

[ii] The concern about being dependent on human charity (literally 'gifts of flesh and blood') reflects both practical worries about dignity in old age or illness, and a spiritual emphasis on dependence on God alone. This prayer appears in several rabbinic sources, including Rabbi Nechunya ben HaKanah's prayer when entering the study hall.

[iii] This concluding phrase reflects the Jewish concept that generations are spiritually connected and will reunite in the World to Come. The fear of shame before one's ancestors serves as a powerful motivation for ethical behavior and spiritual preparation in this life.

[iv] Cf. Ethics of the Fathers (Pirkei Avot) 2:9 — The prayer adopts and expands upon this classic rabbinic blessing, showing how Ma'avar Yabok incorporates traditional ethical teachings into its approach to spiritual preparation for death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berachot 28b — The prayer echoes Rabbi Nechunya's petition not to be dependent on human charity, suggesting that spiritual preparation for death includes cultivating independence and dignity. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fourth Discourse — This prayer appears to be part of the Tannaitic and Amoraic material integrated into Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences, providing ethical guidance for those contemplating mortality.

[i] This formulaic opening 'May it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers' is standard in Jewish petitionary prayers, connecting individual requests to the covenant relationship established with the patriarchs.

וְתַשְׁבִּית עוֹלוֹ שֶׁל יֵצֶר הָרָע
מִלִּבֵּנוּ שֶׁכְּבָר בְּרָאתָנוּ לַעֲשׂוֹת
רְצוֹנֶךָ וְאָנוּ חַיָּבִים לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹנֶךָ
אַתָּה חָפֵץ וְאָנוּ חֲפֵצִים וּמִי מְעַכֵּב
שְׁאוֹר שֶׁבָּעִיסָה:[i] גָּלוּי וְיָדוּעַ
לְפָנֶיךָ שֶׁאֵין בָּנוּ כֹּחַ לַעֲמֹד בּוֹ
אֶלָּא יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ
וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתַּשְׁבִּיתֵהוּ
מֵעָלֵינוּ וְתַכְנִיעֵהוּ וְנַעֲשֶׂה רְצוֹנֶךָ
כִּרְצוֹנֵנוּ בְּלֵבָב שָׁלֵם וְתַשְׁכֵּן
בְּתוֹכֵנוּ אַהֲבָה אַחֲוָה שָׁלוֹם וְרֵעוּת
וְתַצְלִיחַ סוֹפֵנוּ אַחֲרִית וְתִקְוָה
וְתַרְחִיב גְּבוּלֵנוּ בְּתַלְמִידִים וְנָשִׂישׂ
בְּחֶלְקֵנוּ בְּגַן עֵדֶן וְתַקְנֵנוּ לֵב טוֹב
וְחָבֵר טוֹב וְנַשְׁכִּים וְנִמְצָא יְחוּל
לִבֵּנוּ וְתָבֹא לְפָנֶיךָ קוֹרַת נַפְשֵׁנוּ
לְטוֹבָה: וּבֵן יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתִּסְלַח
וְתִמְחוֹל לָנוּ עַל כָּל עֲוֹנוֹתֵינוּ
וּפְשָׁעֵינוּ וּתְכַפֵּר לָנוּ עַל כָּל
חַטֹּאתֵינוּ: אָנָּא אֱלוֹהַּ הָרַחֲמִים
בַּעַל הַסְּלִיחוֹת סְלַח לָנוּ מְחוֹל
לָנוּ כַּפֵּר לָנוּ וְתַמְרוֹק עֲוֹנוֹתֵינוּ
בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים אֲבָל לֹא עַל

yoke of the evil inclination from our hearts, for thus
You created us to do Your will, and we are obli- 4835R
gated to do Your will. You desire, and we desire,
so what hinders us? The leaven in the dough.[A1] It
is revealed and known before You that we have no
power to withstand it. Therefore, may it be Your
will, LORD our God and God of our fathers, that 4840R
You remove it from us and subdue it,[B] and we will
do Your will as our own will, with a whole heart. May
You establish within us love, brotherhood, peace,
and friendship.[2] May You grant success to our final
end and hope, and increase our territory with disci- 4845R
ples. May we rejoice in our portion in the Garden of
Eden,[C] and may You prepare for us a good heart and
a good companion. May we rise early and find our
hearts' anticipation,[D] and may the contentment of
our souls come before You for good. And so, may it 4850R
be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers,
that You forgive and pardon us for all our iniquities
and transgressions, and atone for us for all our sins.
Please, God of compassion, Master of forgiveness,
forgive us, pardon us, atone for us, and cleanse our 4855R
iniquities[E] through Your abundant mercies—but not
through suffering and evil illnesses.[3] May we never

[A] Or: "The yeast in the dough" — The term refers to the evil inclination metaphorically as yeast or leaven that causes dough to rise or swell with pride. Both translations are accurate, but 'yeast' might be more immediately understood by modern readers.

[B] Or: "and humble it" — The Hebrew root כנע carries connotations of humbling or bringing low, not just subduing. 'Humble it' might better capture the spiritual dimension of this request.

[C] Or: "May we rejoice in our share in Paradise" — While 'Garden of Eden' is the literal translation, 'Paradise' is often used in English religious contexts to refer to the same concept and might resonate better with some readers.

[D] Or: "May we arise early and discover what our hearts yearn for" — The phrase יְחוּל לִבֵּנוּ can be interpreted as the yearning or waiting of our hearts, not just anticipation. This alternate translation captures the emotional quality of longing that might be present in the original.

[E] Or: "and scour away our iniquities" — The Hebrew מרק carries a sense of scouring or thoroughly cleansing, which is stronger than simple cleansing. This alternate translation better captures the intensity of the purification being requested.

[1] This is a direct translation of a talmudic expression referring to the evil inclination. The metaphor compares the evil inclination to leaven/yeast that causes dough to swell, representing how evil desires inflate within a person.

[2] This sequence of four positive qualities (love, brotherhood, peace, and friendship) follows a pattern common in rabbinic blessings, creating a comprehensive description of ideal human relationships that stand in contrast to the divisiveness caused by the evil inclination.

[1] This qualification reflects an important theological nuance: while traditional Jewish thought recognizes suffering as potentially atoning, this prayer specifically requests atonement through divine mercy rather than through painful experiences—particularly relevant in a text focused on care for the ill and dying.

[i] A rabbinic metaphor for the evil inclination (yetzer hara), comparing it to leaven or yeast that causes dough to rise—suggesting how pride and evil desires can inflate within a person and cause spiritual corruption.

יְדֵי יִסּוּרִין וַחֳלָיִים רָעִים[ii] וְלֹא נָשׁוּב עוֹד מֵאַחֲרֶיךָ וְנִזְכֶּה לְנוֹעַם יְדִידוּתֶיךָ:[i]

again turn away from You,[4] and may we merit the pleasantness of Your beloved presence.

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׁתִּתֶּן לָנוּ חַיִּים אֲרוּכִים חַיִּים שֶׁל שָׁלוֹם חַיִּים שֶׁל טוֹבָה חַיִּים שֶׁל בְּרָכָה חַיִּים שֶׁל פַּרְנָסָה חַיִּים שֶׁל חִלּוּץ עֶצֶמוֹת[ii] חַיִּים שֶׁיֵּשׁ בָּהֶם יִרְאַת חֵטְא חַיִּים שֶׁאֵין בָּהֶם בּוּשָׁה וּכְלִמָּה חַיִּים שֶׁל עֹשֶׁר וְכָבוֹד חַיִּים שֶׁתְּהֵא בָּנוּ אַהֲבַת תּוֹרָה וְיִרְאַת שָׁמַיִם חַיִּים שֶׁתְּמַלֵּא לָנוּ כָּל מִשְׁאֲלוֹת לִבֵּנוּ לְטוֹבָה בִּזְכוּת הַתַּנָּאִים וְהָאֲמוֹרָאִים זְרוֹעוֹת וְיַרְכִּין מִסְטָרָא דִּקְדֻשָּׁה[iii] אֲשֶׁר אִיתָן מוֹשָׁבָם[iv] וּבִזְכוּת הַצַּדִּיקִים הַקְּבוּרִים בַּמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה וּבִפְרָט זְכוּת צַדִּיק פְּלוֹנִי יָגֵן עָלֵינוּ וְעַל כָּל בָּנַי בֵּיתֵנוּ וְתִהְיֶה

May it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our ancestors, that You grant us long life, a life of peace, a life of goodness, a life of blessing, a life of sustenance, a life of bodily vigor, a life containing fear of sin, a life free of shame and humiliation, a life of wealth and honor, a life in which we may have love of Torah and fear of heaven, a life in which You fulfill all the desires of our heart for good—through the merit of the Tannaim and Amoraim, the arms and thighs of the side of holiness,[1] whose dwelling is mighty, and through the merit of the righteous ones buried in this place, and especially the merit of [specific righteous person], may he protect us and all the members of our household. May my prayer be pure before the Dweller on High, to benefit me and my offspring and my offspring's offspring in this world, with length of days and years of life and peace, and in the World to

[2]The Hebrew phrase uses a construction that implies turning backward or retreating from God's presence, suggesting not merely sinning but actively distancing oneself from the divine relationship.
[3]This unusual metaphorical description of the Tannaim and Amoraim reflects kabbalistic concepts about how these rabbinic sages embody divine attributes within the cosmic structure. The arms and thighs represent strength and support in the divine realm.

[i]This specific request for cleansing 'not through suffering and evil illnesses' represents an important theological position in Jewish thought that acknowledges suffering can be atoning but expresses the preference for divine mercy over painful purification.
[ii]Cf. Talmud Berakhot 17a — This prayer's inclusion in Ma'avar Yabok demonstrates how the author incorporates traditional rabbinic prayers into his work on death and dying, suggesting that preparing for death involves the same spiritual struggles addressed in daily prayer—particularly overcoming the evil inclination. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 17b — The author draws from established rabbinic prayer formulations, placing preparation for death within the context of traditional Jewish spiritual practice rather than creating entirely new liturgical forms. | Cf. Genesis Rabbah 34:10 — By using this established rabbinic metaphor, the prayer connects the spiritual preparation for death with the lifelong struggle against the evil inclination, suggesting that conquering this inclination is a crucial part of preparing for the afterlife. | Cf. Daily Amidah Prayer — By using this familiar prayer structure, the author places preparation for death within the framework of daily Jewish prayer, suggesting that the spiritual work of preparing for death is an extension of regular spiritual practice. | Cf. Yom Kippur Confessional Prayers — By incorporating language from Yom Kippur confessions, the prayer draws a parallel between the Day of Atonement and preparation for death, suggesting that approaching death requires similar spiritual cleansing and forgiveness.
[iii]The term 'chilutz atzamot' (literally 'extraction of bones') idiomatically refers to physical vigor and health, drawing on imagery from Isaiah 58:11 where God promises to 'invigorate your bones.'
[iv]This passage uses technical kabbalistic terminology, describing the Tannaim and Amoraim (early rabbinic sages) as 'arms and thighs from the side of holiness.' This metaphor portrays them as embodiments of divine attributes within the cosmic structure, representing strength and support in the divine realm.
[i]The phrase 'eitan moshavam' (their dwelling is mighty/firm) may allude to Balaam's prophecy in Numbers 24:21 regarding the Kenites whose 'dwelling is strong' (eitan moshavecha), reapplied here to describe the eternal spiritual stature of the sages.

תְּפִלָּתִי זַכָּה לִפְנֵי שׁוֹכֵן מְעוֹנָהּ
לְהֵיטִיב לִי וּלְזַרְעִי וּלְזֶרַע
זַרְעִי בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה בְּאֹרֶךְ יָמִים
4585 וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא
לְהִתְעַלֵּס בְּאַהֲבָה רַבָּה וּבְאַהֲבָה
זוּטָא[i] וְנַפְשׁוֹ בְּטוּב תָּלִין וְתִשְׂבַּע
בְּצַחֲצָחוֹת[ii] וְעַצְמוֹתָיו יַחֲלִיץ
וְרוּחוֹ יִתְאַדֶּר בְּגַן עֵדֶן וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ
4590 תְּרוּשָׁן בְּגַן עֵדֶן עֶלְיוֹן וּבְצֵרוֹר
הַחַיִּים עִם יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְעַצְמוֹתָיו
יְנוּחוּן וְיָרְיוּן מִדֶּשֶׁן בֵּיתוֹ וְכָל
שִׁכְבֵי עַמּוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל בִּכְלַל הָרַחֲמִים
וְהַסְּלִיחוֹת וְהַנֶּחָמוֹת וְנֹאמַר אָמֵן:
4595 עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ. עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן
יְמִינֶךָ. עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן תּוֹרָתֶךָ. עֲשֵׂה
לְמַעַן קְדוּשָּׁתֶךָ: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי
פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי
וְגוֹאֲלִי:[iii]

Come to delight in great love and lesser love.[2] May his soul abide in goodness and be satisfied with clear radiance;[1] may his bones be invigorated, his spirit be glorified in the Garden of Eden, and his soul be made abundant in the supernal Garden of Eden and in the bond of life with the LORD our God. May his bones rest and be saturated with the abundance of His house,[2] and may all the deceased of His people Israel be included in compassion, forgiveness, and consolation. And let us say: Amen. Act for the sake of Your name. Act for the sake of Your right hand. Act for the sake of Your Torah. Act for the sake of Your holiness.[3] May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.

4600 עוד תפלה על הקבר נתקנה בפיראר״ה[iv][v]

Another Prayer at the Grave Established in Ferrara

[1]These terms (‘ahavah rabbah’ and ‘ahavah zuta’) are technical kabbalistic concepts referring to different levels or types of divine love and unification in the spiritual realms.

[2]This phrase translates ‘tzachtzachot,’ which appears in Isaiah 58:11. While literally referring to ‘parched places,’ in this mystical context it describes spiritual illumination and divine satisfaction in the afterlife.

[3]This draws on imagery from Psalm 36:8-9 about being satisfied with the abundance of God’s house, adapting it to describe the soul’s nourishment in the afterlife.

[4]This formulaic conclusion is a traditional litany of appeals to different aspects of divine authority and attributes, commonly found in Jewish liturgical prayers seeking divine intervention.

[ii]The terms ‘ahavah rabbah’ (great love) and ‘ahavah zuta’ (lesser love) are kabbalistic concepts describing different modes or intensities of divine love and unification. In Lurianic Kabbalah, they represent different types of spiritual unions between divine aspects.

[iii]The term ‘tzachtzachot’ comes from Isaiah 58:11, where God promises to satisfy the soul in ‘parched places’ or with ‘clear radiance.’ In kabbalistic interpretation, this represents spiritual nourishment in the highest realms.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 90:10-17 — The prayer draws on traditional biblical language about longevity as a divine blessing | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 16b-17a — This prayer directly quotes or closely parallels the personal supplication attributed to Rav in the Talmud, showing how Ma’avar Yabok integrates traditional rabbinic texts into its liturgy for the sick and dying | Cf. Zohar III:29b — The kabbalistic terminology about souls being bound in the ‘bond of life’ and enjoying the ‘supernal Garden of Eden’ reflects Zoharic teachings about the afterlife | Cf. Psalm 36:8-9 — The prayer adapts this psalm’s imagery of divine abundance to describe the soul’s nourishment in the afterlife | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — The phrases ‘be satisfied with clear radiance’ and ‘may his bones be invigorated’ directly echo Isaiah’s prophetic language about divine blessing

[i]Ferrara was an important center of Jewish life and learning in Renaissance Italy. The city’s Jewish community flourished particularly in the 16th century after Jews were expelled from the Iberian Peninsula. This attribution indicates that Rabbi Aaron Berechia was collecting prayers from various Italian Jewish communities and incorporating them into his work.

[ii]Cf. Ma’avar Yabok — This prayer appears to be part of the collection of cemetery prayers in Ma’avar Yabok. The designation of Ferrara as its origin connects it to the Italian Jewish community where Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena was active, showing how the author incorporated regional liturgical traditions into his work. | Cf. Hashkavah prayers — This appears to be a specific

שָׁלוֹם עֲלֵיכֶם מוֹרַי וְרַבּוֹתַי[i] תְּהִי
נַפְשְׁכֶם צְרוּרָה בִּצְרוֹר הַחַיִּים
אֶת יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ שָׁלוֹם עֲלֵיכֶם
וְעַל מִשְׁכְּבוֹתֵיכֶם יְהִי שָׁלוֹם
בְּמָנוּחָתְכֶם אַשְׁרֵיכֶם אַתֶּם אֲשֶׁר
זְכִיתֶם לָלֶכֶת בְּדַרְכֵי יוֹצְרֵנוּ
מְזֻמָּנִים אַתֶּם לְחַיֵּי הָעוֹלָם הַבָּא
בְּמַעֲלוֹת הַצַּדִּיקִים אַתֶּם יוֹשְׁבִים
עִם הַמַּלְאָכִים הַקְּדוֹשִׁים אֲשֶׁר אָצַל
בְּנֵי עֲלִיָּה: וַיהוָה יָחִישׁ עֲמִידַתְכֶם
וְיִמַהֵר עֲמִידַתְכֶם[ii] וְיִזַּכְּנוּ לִרְאוֹת
פְּנֵיכֶם מְאִירִים וּמַזְהִירִים כְּזֹהַר
הָרָקִיעַ זְכוּתְכֶם וּתְמִימוּתְכֶם
יַעֲמֹד לָנוּ וְתוֹרַתְכֶם תָּגֵן בַּעֲדֵנוּ:
(ואם היא עת מלחמה יוסיף
ויאמר לְעֵת הַזֹּאת אֲשֶׁר אֲנַחְנוּ
בְּצָרָה גְּדוֹלָה וְסַכָּנָה עֲצוּמָה
מִקּוֹל תְּרוּעַת מִלְחָמָה אֲשֶׁר
בְּאָזְנֵינוּ אֲנַחְנוּ שׁוֹמְעִים וְעֵינֵינוּ
רוֹאוֹת קְבוּצֵי גְיָסוֹת וּכְלֵי מִלְחָמָה
נֶאֱסָפִים בְּגָלִילוֹת הָאֵלֶּה מַעֲרָכָה
לִקְרַאת מַעֲרָכָה) יָבוֹא שָׁלוֹם יָנוּחַ
עַל מִשְׁכַּבְכֶם וְגַם אַתֶּם כָּמוֹנוּ
תַּרְבּוּ תְּפִלָּה בַּעֲדֵנוּ הַעְתִּירוּ אֶל
יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ כִּי לְמַעַן רַחֲמָיו הָרַבִּים
וַחֲסָדָיו הַגְּדוֹלִים וּלְמַעַן זְכוּת
אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק וְיַעֲקֹב אֲבוֹתֵינוּ
הַקְּדוֹשִׁים וּזְכוּת כָּל הַצַּדִּיקִים
שֶׁעָשׂוּ רְצוֹנוֹ יָחוֹס וְיַחֲמֹל וְיִרַחֵם

Peace be upon you, our teachers and our masters.[1] May your souls be bound in the bond of life with the LORD our God. Peace be upon you, and upon your resting places may there be peace in your repose. Fortunate are you who merited to walk in the ways of our Creator. You are destined for the life of the World to Come. You dwell among the holy angels in the company of the most exalted ones.[A] May the LORD hasten your resurrection and accelerate your rising,[B] and may He grant us merit to see your faces shining and radiant like the brightness of the firmament.[2] May your merit and your integrity stand for us, and may your Torah protect us.

(And if it is a time of war, he should add and say:[3] At this time when we are in great distress and immense danger from the sound of the battle cry which we hear with our ears, and our eyes see troops gathering and weapons of war being assembled in these regions, battle line facing battle line.)

May peace come and rest upon your resting place, and may you also, like us, increase prayer on our behalf. Entreat the LORD our God that for the sake of His abundant mercies and His great kindnesses, and for the sake of the merit of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, our holy forefathers, and the merit of all the righteous who have done His will, He may have compassion, and show mercy, and protect us and our wives and our children and our infants, and the

[A] Or: "among the elevated souls" — The term 'bnei aliyah' literally means 'children of ascent' and is a rabbinic term for spiritually elevated individuals. This alternate translation is more literal while still conveying the concept of spiritual elevation.

[B] Or: "and hasten your standing [at resurrection]" — The term 'amidatkhem' refers specifically to standing up, which in this context is a reference to resurrection. This alternate translation makes the resurrection imagery more explicit.

[1] This prayer belongs to a category of cemetery prayers in Ma'avar Yabok that address the deceased directly rather than speaking about them in the third person. This reflects the Jewish belief that the souls of the departed remain conscious and can hear the words of the living.

[2] This is an allusion to Daniel 12:3, which describes how 'the wise shall shine like the brightness of the firmament' in the messianic age. The prayer thus connects the current state of the righteous dead with their future glorification at the resurrection.

[3] This conditional addition demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok's prayers were designed to be adaptable to different historical circumstances. The 17th century, when this work was composed, was marked by significant wars and conflicts affecting Jewish communities in Europe.

formulation of a Hashkavah (soul repose) prayer developed in the Ferrara Jewish community. Such prayers were recited at gravesites to provide comfort to the soul of the deceased.

[iii] This prayer follows the Jewish tradition of directly addressing the deceased, reflecting the belief that the souls of the departed remain aware and can intercede for the living.

[iv] The repetition of 'hasten' and 'accelerate' regarding resurrection creates a poetic emphasis typical of Hebrew prayer. The term 'amidah' (standing) is a euphemism for resurrection of the dead.

וְגֵן עָלֵינוּ וְעַל נָשֵׁינוּ וְעַל טַפֵּנוּ
וְעוֹלָלֵנוּ וְעַל יֶתֶר פְּלֵיטַת רְכוּשֵׁנוּ
שֶׁלֹּא תְּהֶיֶה לֹא לָבַז וְלֹא לְמִשְׂסָה
וְיַצִּילֵנוּ מֵהֶרֶג וּמִבְּזָה וּמִכָּל
4635 נֶזֶק וְצָרָה וְצוּקָה וְאַל יַעֲלֶם
אָזְנוֹ מִשְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתֵנוּ וְתַחֲנוּנֵנוּ
הַזּוֹעֲקִים לְפָנָיו מִקֵּירוֹת לִבֵּנוּ
לְמַעַן רַחֲמָיו יָחִישׁ מִפְלָט לָנוּ אַל
יַעַזְבֵנוּ וְאַל יִמְשֹׁנוּ וְאַל יִשְׁכַּח
4640 בְּרִית אֲבוֹתֵינוּ[i] כַּאֲשֶׁר הִבְטִיחָנוּ
בְּתוֹרָתוֹ הַקְּדוֹשָׁה עַל יְדֵי מֹשֶׁה
עַבְדּוֹ וְאַף גַּם זֹאת בִּהְיוֹתָם
בְּאֶרֶץ אוֹיְבֵיהֶם לֹא מְאַסְתִּים וְלֹא
גְעַלְתִּים לְכַלּוֹתָם לְהָפֵר בְּרִיתִי
4645 אִתָּם כִּי אֲנִי יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיהֶם: וּכְתִיב
וְזָכַרְתִּי לָהֶם בְּרִית רִאשׁוֹנִים אֲשֶׁר
הוֹצֵאתִי אוֹתָם מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם
לִהְיוֹת לָהֶם לֵאלֹהִים אֲנִי יְיָ: לָכֵן
גַּם אֲנַחְנוּ עֵינֵינוּ וְלִבֵּנוּ אֶל יְיָ
4650 אֱלֹהֵינוּ (בְּצוֹם) וּבְכִי וּצְעָקָה
בִּדְמָעוֹת עַל לְחָיֵינוּ בּוֹרְעִים
וּמִתְוַדִּים עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ[ii] וּמְבַקְּשִׁים
סְלִיחָה וְכַפָּרָה וְעֶזְרָתָה לָנוּ לְעֵת
צָרָה כַּיּוֹם הַזֶּה:[iii]

remainder of our possessions that they not become prey or plunder.[A] May He save us from slaughter and from pillage and from all damage, trouble, and distress. May He not turn His ear from hearing our 4925R
prayers[1] and our supplications that cry out before Him from the depths of our hearts. For the sake of His mercies, may He hasten refuge for us. May He not abandon us, nor forsake us, nor forget the covenant of our forefathers, as He promised us in His 4930R
holy Torah through Moses His servant: "Yet even then, when they are in the land of their enemies, I will not reject them or spurn them so as to destroy them, breaking My covenant with them, for I am the LORD their God." And it is written: "I will remem- 4935R
ber for them the covenant with the ancients, whom I brought out of the land of Egypt in the sight of the nations, to be their God; I am the LORD."

Therefore, we too turn our eyes and our hearts to the LORD our God (with fasting), with weeping and 4940R
crying, with tears upon our cheeks, kneeling and confessing our sins, seeking forgiveness and atonement and help for us in this time of trouble like today.[2]

[A] Or: "spoil or pillage" — These are biblical terms for property taken as war booty. This alternate translation uses different English synonyms that might better convey the biblical language.

[1] The Hebrew uses the idiom 'ya'alem ozno' (turn away His ear), a biblical expression found in Lamentations 3:56 and Psalm 55:2. This anthropomorphic language describes God as actively choosing whether to listen to human prayers.

[2] The prayer concludes with a transition from addressing the dead to a communal confession of the living, creating a spiritual bridge between the two worlds. This reflects the book's central theme of crossing over (ma'avar) between life and death.

[i] The concept of covenant (brit) is central to Jewish theology. This prayer invokes God's covenantal promises as the basis for divine protection, particularly in times of danger.

[ii] The prayer shifts from addressing the deceased to describing the living community's posture of repentance, creating a spiritual connection between the worlds of the living and the dead through shared devotion.

[iii] Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — This biblical reference is foundational to Jewish concepts of the afterlife. In this prayer at the grave, it expresses the belief that the souls of the righteous continue to exist in close proximity to God after death. The phrase appears in traditional Jewish memorial prayers and on tombstones. | Cf. Daniel 12:3 — This reference connects the deceased to the 'wise ones' mentioned in the Book of Daniel who will shine brightly in the messianic age. It suggests that the righteous dead are already experiencing a foretaste of the messianic redemption, while also looking forward to bodily resurrection. | Cf. Leviticus 26:44 — This biblical passage is particularly significant in times of communal danger. The prayer invokes this divine promise of preservation as a basis for requesting divine protection in the present crisis. It reflects the Jewish theological understanding that God's covenant with Israel remains eternally valid despite historical circumstances. | Cf. Leviticus 26:45 — This passage reinforces the appeal to God's covenant faithfulness, specifically referencing the foundational event of the Exodus. By invoking this text, the prayer connects the current community's situation to the historic pattern of divine redemption, suggesting that just as God rescued Israel from Egypt, He can provide deliverance from current dangers.

4655 אָנָּא יְיָ הָאֵל הַגָּדוֹל הַגִּבּוֹר
וְהַנּוֹרָא שׁוֹמֵר הַבְּרִית וְהַחֶסֶד
לְאוֹהֲבָיו וּלְשׁוֹמְרֵי מִצְוֹתָיו חָטָאנוּ
עָוִינוּ וְסָרְנוּ מִמִּצְוֹתֶיךָ וּמִמִּשְׁפָּטֶיךָ
הַטּוֹבִים לְךָ יְיָ הַצְדָּקָה וְלָנוּ בּשֶׁת
4660 הַפָּנִים בַּיּוֹם הַזֶּה לְגָלוּת יְהוּדָה
וְיִשְׂרָאֵל הַקְּרוֹבִים וְהָרְחוֹקִים
בְּכָל הָאֲרָצוֹת אֲשֶׁר הִדַּחְתָּם שָׁם
בְּמַעֲלָם אֲשֶׁר מָעֲלוּ בָךְ:[i] יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵינוּ לָנוּ בּשֶׁת הַפָּנִים לְזִקְנֵינוּ
4665 לְשׁוֹפְטֵינוּ וְלַחֲכָמֵינוּ וּלְמַנְהִיגֵי
דּוֹרֵנוּ וּלְכָל עַם הָאָרֶץ כִּי כֻלָּנוּ
כַּצֹּאן תָּעִינוּ אִישׁ לְדַרְכּוֹ פָּנִינוּ
לְהַבְלֵי הָעוֹלָם לְבִלְתִּי פְּנוֹת
וּלְבִלְתִּי שְׁמוֹעַ לְדִבְרֵי תוֹרָתְךָ
4670 הַקְּדוֹשָׁה לִשְׁמֹר וְלַעֲשׂוֹת בְּכָל
הַכָּתוּב בָּהּ וּלְבִלְתִּי עֶסֶק בַּתּוֹרָה
לִשְׁמָהּ.[ii] עַל כֵּן בָּאָה עָלֵינוּ
הַצָּרָה הַזֹּאת לְךָ יְיָ הַצְדָּקָה וּלְךָ יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵינוּ הָרַחֲמִים וְהַסְּלִיחוֹת:[iii]

Please, O LORD, the God great, mighty, and awesome,[1] who keeps the covenant and mercy for 4945R
those who love Him and keep His commandments—
we have sinned, we have done wrong, and we have
turned away from Your commandments and from
Your good judgments. To You, O LORD, belongs
righteousness, and to us belongs shame of face this 4950R
day, for the exile of Judah and Israel,[A] those near
and those far away in all the lands where You have
driven them[2] because of their unfaithfulness with
which they have been unfaithful to You. O LORD
our God, we have shame of face—our elders, our 4955R
judges, our sages, the leaders of our generation, and
all the people of the land, for we have all strayed like
sheep,[B] each turning to his own way, to the vanities
of this world, neither turning to nor listening to the
words of Your holy Torah to keep and to do all that 4960R
is written in it, and not engaging in Torah study
for its own sake. Therefore this trouble has come
upon us.[3] To You, O LORD, belongs righteousness,
and to You, O LORD our God, belong mercy and
forgiveness. 4965R

[A] Or: "for the dispersed ones of Judah and Israel" — The term galut can refer to both the state of exile and to the exiled people themselves. This alternate translation emphasizes the people in exile rather than the condition of exile.

[B] Or: "for all of us like sheep have gone astray" — This alternate more directly echoes the famous phrasing from Isaiah 53:6, which is likely being deliberately invoked in this prayer. The biblical allusion might be more recognizable to readers with this phrasing.

[1] This tripartite description of God comes from Deuteronomy 10:17 and was incorporated into the standard Jewish liturgy. The prayer is opening with a traditional formulation that would be immediately recognizable to Jewish worshippers.

[2] This reference to exile (galut) is a central theme in Jewish theological understanding of history, interpreting dispersion as divine punishment for covenant unfaithfulness rather than merely political circumstances.

[3] The prayer reflects the theological framework of Ma'avar Yabok that suffering is not random misfortune but divinely ordained as correction for spiritual failings, connecting present troubles directly to religious shortcomings.

[i] The term ma'al (unfaithfulness/trespass) has specific connotations in biblical Hebrew of breach of trust, especially in a covenantal relationship. It's stronger than ordinary sin, suggesting betrayal of God's trust.

[ii] The concept of Torah lishmah (Torah study for its own sake, without ulterior motives) is a fundamental principle in rabbinic Judaism. The confession here acknowledges failing to maintain this pure intention in Torah study.

[i] Cf. Daniel 9:4-19 — This prayer in Ma'avar Yabok is deliberately structured after Daniel's confession, creating a direct connection between the biblical exile and the contemporary exile experience of the Jewish community. By using this biblical model, the author positions current suffering within a historical pattern of sin, confession, and hoped-for redemption. | Cf. Daily Amidah prayer — The prayer draws on familiar liturgical patterns, particularly from penitential prayers, creating a sense of continuity between standard daily worship and the special circumstances of mourning or illness that would prompt the use of Ma'avar Yabok.

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁלֹּא יִשְׁלֹט כָּל חֵטְא וְעָוֹן אֶת תְּפִלָּתֵנוּ. וְעַתָּה יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ הַבֵּט נָא וּרְאֵה אֶת עָנְיֵנוּ. כִּי בְצָרָה גְדוֹלָה אֲנַחְנוּ נְשֵׁינוּ וּבָנֵינוּ טַפֵּנוּ וְעוֹלְלֵינוּ. הַרְבֵּה נָא חַסְדְּךָ עִמָּנוּ וְהַצִּילֵנוּ מִמַּכַּת חֶרֶב וְהֶרֶג בַּר מִינָן [i] וּמִבְּיזָה וְשִׁבְיָה וּמִכָּל נֶזֶק וְצָרָה וְחוּס וַחֲמוֹל עָלֵינוּ וְעַל עוֹלְלֵינוּ וְעַל טַפֵּנוּ וְהָסֵר כָּל נֶזֶק וְכָל צָרָה מֵעָלֵינוּ. עֲשֵׂה נָא יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ עֲשֵׂה אַל תְּאַחַר לְמַעַן קְדוּשַׁת שִׁמְךָ הַגָּדוֹל אֲשֶׁר עָלֵינוּ נִקְרָא [ii] אַל תַּנִּיחֵנוּ וְאַל תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנּוּ כִּי צַר לָנוּ מַהֵר עֲנֵנוּ: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי: [iii]

May it be Your will that no sin or iniquity impede our prayer. And now, O LORD our God, look down and behold our affliction.[A] For we are in great distress[1]—we, our wives, our children, our little ones, and our infants.[B] Please increase Your kindness toward us and save us from the plague of the sword and from death (God forbid[C]), from plunder and captivity, and from all damage and distress. Have pity and compassion upon us, upon our infants, and upon our little ones, and remove all harm and all distress from us. Act now, O LORD our God, act without delay for the sake of Your great and holy Name that is called upon us.[2] Do not abandon us, and do not hide Your face from us, for we are in distress—answer us quickly. May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.

[A] Or: "please gaze upon and see our suffering" — The Hebrew uses two visual verbs ('habeṭ' and 'u-re'eh') with the particle 'na' indicating entreaty. While 'look down and behold' captures the sense well, 'please gaze upon and see' might better preserve both the dual visual imagery and the entreating nature of 'na'.

[B] Or: "our children and our babes" — The Hebrew terms 'tap' and 'olalim' both refer to young children of different ages. The distinction between 'little ones' and 'infants' captures this, but 'children and babes' is another valid translation that preserves the poetic parallelism.

[C] Or: "heaven forbid" — The Aramaic phrase 'bar minan' (literally 'external to us') is an euphemistic way of referring to something negative without directly stating it. 'Heaven forbid' is another common English rendering that preserves the euphemistic nature of the expression.

[1] This prayer appears to have been composed for times of community crisis or persecution, referencing threats of violence, plunder, and captivity that were historical realities for many Jewish communities throughout history.

[2] This phrase invokes God's intervention not primarily based on human merit but on God's own reputation and covenant relationship with Israel. The concept that God's name is 'called upon' the Jewish people derives from biblical passages like Deuteronomy 28:10.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase literally means "external to us" and is a euphemistic way to say "God forbid" or "may it not happen to us." It is commonly used when mentioning death or other calamities to ward off their occurrence.

[iii] This phrase refers to the concept that the Jewish people bear God's name, making them both protected by and responsible to God. The appeal to God's name is a common motif in Jewish prayer, based on the idea that God will act to preserve the honor of His name.

[i] Cf. Psalms 19:15 — The prayer concludes with this direct quotation from Psalms 19:15, a verse commonly used to end prayers in Jewish liturgy. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves as a formal closure to the supplication, expressing hope that both the articulated words and the unspoken thoughts of the heart will be accepted by God. | Cf. Lamentations 5:1 — This phrase echoes Lamentations 5:1 ('Remember, O LORD, what has befallen us; look, and see our disgrace'). In Ma'avar Yabok, this allusion to Lamentations connects the present suffering to the biblical paradigm of national calamity, suggesting that individual affliction is part of a larger pattern of divine-human interaction where looking to God for salvation is the appropriate response. | Cf. Daniel 9:19 — This phrasing echoes Daniel 9:19's urgent appeal: 'O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive; O Lord, pay attention and act. Delay not, for your own sake.' In Ma'avar Yabok, this reference frames the prayer as part of the traditional Jewish understanding of pleading with God in times of crisis, emphasizing both the urgency of the situation and God's sovereignty.

כשנפטרין מבתי חיים אומרים[ii][i] When departing from cemeteries,[A] one recites:

אָמַר רַבָּה בַּר בַּר חָנָה אָמַר רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן[iii] עֲתִידִים צַדִּיקִים שֶׁיִּקָּרְאוּ עַל שְׁמוֹ שֶׁל הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר כֹּל הַנִּקְרָא בִּשְׁמִי וְלִכְבוֹדִי בְּרָאתִיו יְצַרְתִּיו אַף עָשִׂיתִיו:[iv] אָמַר רַבִּי אֶלְעָזָר עֲתִידִים צַדִּיקִים שֶׁיְּאֻמַּר לִפְנֵיהֶם קָדוֹשׁ בְּדֶרֶךְ שֶׁאוֹמְרִים לְפָנָיו הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר וְהָיָה הַנִּשְׁאָר בְּצִיּוֹן וְהַנּוֹתָר בִּירוּשָׁלַיִם קָדוֹשׁ יֵאָמֵר לוֹ[v] כָּל הַכָּתוּב לְחַיִּים בִּירוּשָׁלָיִם וְנֶאֱמַר וְיִשְׂמְחוּ כָּל חוֹסֵי בָךְ לְעוֹלָם יְרַנְּנוּ וְתָסֵךְ עָלֵימוֹ וְיַעֲלְצוּ בְךָ אוֹהֲבֵי

Rabbah bar bar Chanah said in the name of Rabbi Yochanan: In the future, the righteous will be called by the name of the Holy One, blessed be He,[B] as it is said (Isaiah 43:7): "Everyone who is called by My name, whom I have created for My glory, whom I have formed, indeed whom I have made." Rabbi Elazar said: In the future, the righteous will be addressed as "holy" in the same way[1] that one addresses the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is said (Isaiah 4:3): "And it shall be that he who remains in Zion and he who is left in Jerusalem will be called holy—everyone who is recorded among the living in Jerusalem." And it is further said (Psalm 5:12): "And all who take refuge in You will rejoice, they will

4985R 4990R 4995R

[A] Or: "When taking leave of the houses of the living" — This is a more literal translation of 'batei chayyim' (houses of the living), which is a Hebrew euphemism for cemetery. The euphemism reflects the Jewish belief in the continuation of life after death and would preserve the original text's reverent tone.

[B] Or: "The righteous are destined to be called by the name of the Holy One, blessed be He" — The Hebrew 'עֲתִידִים' can be translated as either 'in the future' or 'are destined to,' with the latter capturing more of the sense of divine determination in the original.

[1] The Hebrew term 'kadosh' (holy) is one of the most significant divine attributes in Jewish tradition. The Kedushah prayer, recited daily, proclaims God as 'Holy, Holy, Holy' (based on Isaiah 6:3). Rabbi Elazar's teaching that this term will be applied to the righteous represents an extraordinary elevation of human potential.

[ii] The text uses the euphemistic term 'batei chayyim' (houses of life) rather than 'beit kevarot' (house of graves) or 'beit olam' (house of eternity), reflecting the Jewish theological position that death is not the end of existence but a transition to another form of life. This section introduces prayers to be recited when leaving a cemetery.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 20, Third Discourse — This instruction refers back to rituals discussed earlier in Ma'avar Yabok about proper behavior when leaving a cemetery. The departure rituals were considered important to maintain separation between the realms of the living and the dead, while still honoring the deceased. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 58b — The Talmudic tradition prescribes specific prayers when departing from a cemetery, including affirmations of future resurrection and divine justice. This instruction aligns with that tradition, though Ma'avar Yabok expands these practices with additional kabbalistic elements.

[iv] This citation formula ("X said in the name of Y") is typical of Talmudic literature, indicating the transmission chain of the teaching. Rabbah bar bar Chanah was a third-century Babylonian sage known for his remarkable stories, while Rabbi Yochanan was one of the greatest Palestinian Amoraim (Talmudic sages) of the same period.

[v] This verse from Isaiah 43:7 is reinterpreted here in a novel way. While in its original context it refers to the people of Israel collectively being called by God's name, Rabbi Yochanan applies it to individual righteous people who will attain such spiritual elevation that they will bear God's name.

[i] The term 'holy' (kadosh) is one of the primary attributes used to describe God in Jewish liturgy, particularly in the Kedushah prayer where the angels proclaim 'Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts.' Rabbi Elazar's statement suggests that the righteous will share in this divine attribute to such an extent that they will be addressed with the same title.

[ii] Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Bava Batra 75b — This passage serves to emphasize the exalted status that the righteous will attain in the messianic future. By being called by God's name and addressed as 'holy,' they will share in divine attributes. This reflects the Jewish theological concept that

שְׁמֶךָ:[vi]

sing for joy forever, and You will shelter them;[A] and those who love Your name will exult in You."

תפלה זו טוב להתמיד להתפלל אותה על הקבר בלשון יחיד בעת שמבקר אדם את מתו
4710 כדפסק מהר״י קארו[i] ביורה דעה סוף סימן מש״ד.[ii] ובתוך השנה. ובפרט בשלשים יום הראשונים. ובכל פעם קודם בקשת רחמים על עצמו או על
4715 ישראל החיים במקום שוכני

It is good to make a habit of praying this prayer at the grave[B] in the singular form[1] when a person visits his deceased,[2] as ruled by Rabbi Joseph Karo in Yoreh De'ah at the end of section 344.[C] This should be done during the year of mourning, especially during the first thirty days. Each time, before requesting mercy for oneself or for the living people of Israel in the place of those who dwell in the dust,[iii] it is good to first recite this prayer and afterward ask 5000R 5005R

[A] Or: "And all who seek refuge in You will rejoice; forever they will sing joyously, and You will spread Your protection over them" — This alternative more explicitly conveys the image of divine protection implied by 'וְתָסֵךְ עָלֵימוֹ' (which has connotations of covering or shielding) while maintaining the poetic structure of the verse.

[B] Or: "It is beneficial to regularly recite this prayer at the gravesite" — This alternate translation might be preferable in contexts that emphasize the functional benefits of the practice rather than its moral goodness. It also uses 'regularly recite' instead of 'make a habit of praying' for a more formal tone.

[C] Or: "in accordance with the ruling of Rabbi Joseph Karo in Yoreh De'ah, section 344" — This alternate translation removes the potentially confusing 'at the end of' phrasing and uses the more formal 'in accordance with' to emphasize the halakhic authority being cited.

[1] The original text specifies 'בלשון יחיד' (in singular language), meaning the prayer should be addressed directly to the individual deceased person being visited, rather than using plural forms that might apply to all the dead.

[2] The phrase 'מבקר אדם את מתו' literally means 'when a person visits his dead one,' referring to visiting the grave of a relative or loved one. This reflects Jewish custom of maintaining connection with the deceased through grave visitation.

human beings can attain a level of spiritual perfection that brings them into closer alignment with divine qualities. | Cf. Isaiah 43:7 — Rabbi Yochanan reinterprets this verse, which originally referred to Israel as a nation, to suggest that the righteous will individually bear God's name in the future world. This exemplifies the rabbinic method of applying scriptural verses beyond their original context to teach new theological concepts. | Cf. Isaiah 4:3 — Rabbi Elazar uses this verse to demonstrate that the righteous will be addressed as 'holy,' a title usually reserved for God. This interpretation elevates human potential to an extraordinary degree, suggesting that through righteousness, humans can attain a status approaching the divine. | Cf. Psalm 5:12 — This verse is added as supporting evidence for the special relationship between God and the righteous. It emphasizes both the protection God provides ('וְתָסֵךְ עָלֵימוֹ'—You will shelter them) and the spiritual joy experienced by those who love God's name, reinforcing the connection between righteous humans and divine qualities. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The inclusion of this passage in Ma'avar Yabok's cemetery departure prayers serves to comfort mourners by emphasizing the exalted status that the righteous dead will attain in the World to Come. It transforms the sorrow of death into hope for the spiritual elevation of the deceased, reassuring the living that their departed loved ones will achieve an extraordinary closeness to God.

[i] This refers to Rabbi Joseph Karo (1488-1575), the author of the Shulchan Aruch, the most authoritative code of Jewish law. The citation establishes halakhic authority for the practice being described.

[ii] This refers to section 344 of Yoreh De'ah, part of the Shulchan Aruch that deals with laws of mourning and grave visitation. The numerical value of the Hebrew letters מש״ד equals 344.

[iii] A euphemistic reference to the dead as 'dwellers in the dust,' based on biblical language. This phrase connects to the book's theme of respectful language when discussing death.

עפר[iii] טוב להקדים לומר תפלה זו ואח״כ ישאל צרכיו וזו היא התפלה:[i]

for one's needs. This is the prayer:[1]

שָׁלָם רַב וְטַב מֵרִבּוֹן טַב[ii] עַל כֻּלְכֶם מוֹרֵינוּ וְרַבּוֹתֵינוּ שׁוֹכְנֵי עָפָר:[iii] [iv]

Peace, abundant and good, from the Good Master[A] upon all of you, our teachers and our rabbis,[2] dwellers in the dust.[B] 5010R

4720

אֶקְרָא לֵאלֹהִים עֶלְיוֹן[v] לְאֵל גּוֹמֵר

I will call to God Most High,[3] to the God who fulfills

[A] Or: "Great and good peace from the Benevolent Master" — This alternative captures the Aramaic quality of the phrase, which uses 'shalam' (שְׁלָם) rather than the Hebrew 'shalom' (שָׁלוֹם). The term 'Ribon Tav' could also be rendered as 'Benevolent Master' to maintain the poetic repetition of 'tav' (good) in the original.

[B] Or: "those who rest in the earth" — This alternative avoids the potentially negative connotation of 'dust' and emphasizes the peaceful resting state of the deceased. It's less literal but might better convey the respectful tone of addressing the dead in a cemetery prayer context.

[1] The original text ends with this introduction to the prayer that would follow, but the prayer itself is not included in this passage. In the original text of Ma'avar Yabok, the full prayer would appear next.

[2] This direct address to the deceased with honorific titles reflects the Jewish belief that the righteous dead maintain awareness and can intercede for the living. It shows continuity of relationship despite death and demonstrates profound respect for their continuing spiritual influence.

[3] The Hebrew begins with the first-person singular imperfect verb 'I will call,' establishing this as a personal prayer of commitment rather than an imperative or communal declaration.

[iv] Cf. Yoreh De'ah — The text references the halakhic code Yoreh De'ah compiled by Rabbi Joseph Karo, specifically citing his ruling about proper practices when visiting graves. This establishes the legal foundation for the prayer practice being described. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage appears in Ma'avar Yabok as part of the practical prayer instructions for visiting graves. It represents the book's broader purpose of providing detailed ritual guidance for those performing acts of kindness for the deceased.

[v] This opening phrase is in Aramaic rather than Hebrew, as evidenced by the use of 'shalam' (שְׁלָם) instead of the Hebrew 'shalom' (שָׁלוֹם) for 'peace.' Aramaic was commonly used in Jewish funerary contexts and prayers for the dead, possibly to distinguish these prayers from everyday Hebrew liturgy and to connect with the language of the Kaddish prayer.

[vi] This euphemism for the dead ('dwellers in the dust') connects to biblical passages about resurrection, particularly Daniel 12:2 which refers to 'those who sleep in the dust of the earth.' This phrase acknowledges death while subtly affirming the Jewish belief in eventual resurrection.

[vii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, prayer for visiting graves — This opening line appears to be part of a cemetery prayer from Ma'avar Yabok used when visiting graves. It addresses the deceased in respectful Aramaic terms, acknowledging them as teachers and rabbis. The phrase follows the traditional Jewish practice of addressing the deceased directly during cemetery visits, showing that the boundary between living and dead is permeable through prayer. | Cf. Daniel 12:2 — The phrase 'dwellers in the dust' (שׁוֹכְנֵי עָפָר) echoes Daniel 12:2's reference to 'those who sleep in the dust of the earth' (מִיְּשֵׁנֵי אַדְמַת-עָפָר), connecting this cemetery prayer to biblical passages about resurrection. This subtly communicates that the deceased are not permanently gone but temporarily dwelling in the earth awaiting future revival. | Cf. Talmud, Berakhot 18a-b — The direct address to the dead as 'our teachers and our rabbis' reflects the Talmudic concept that the righteous dead remain conscious of and can intercede for the living. Berakhot 18a-b discusses whether the dead are aware of worldly affairs, and this prayer presupposes such awareness by directly addressing them with honorific titles.

[i] The divine name 'God Most High' (Elohim Elyon) appears frequently in cemetery prayers, emphasizing God's transcendent power over both life and death.

[ii] This phrase comes from Psalm 57:3 where it expresses confidence in God completing His purpose for the psalmist despite dangers. In the context of cemetery prayers, it takes on added significance as an affirmation of God's ongoing purpose that extends beyond death.

עָלָי:[vi] יִשְׁלַח אֱלֹהִים חַסְדּוֹ וַאֲמִתּוֹ
עִם הַחַיִּים וְעִם הַמֵּתִים:[i][ii]

His purpose for me.[A] May God send forth His loving-kindness and His truth with the living and with the dead.[B] 5015R

4725 אֲהֶיֶה יָהּ יְיָ[iii] בְּכֹחַ רַחֲמֶיךָ
וַחֲסָדֶיךָ הַגְּדוֹלִים רַחֵם נָא עַל כָּל
שִׁכְבֵי עַמְּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל. וּבִפְרָט עַל
הַשּׁוֹכְבִים בַּחֲצַר מָוֶת הַזֶּה[iv] כִּי
עִמְּךָ מְקוֹר חַיִּים וְתָמִיד יִתְהַלְּכוּ
4730 נֶגֶד הַחַיִּים וְנַפְשָׁם תֶּהֱא צְרוּרָה

O EHYEH, YAH, ADONAI,[C] through the power of Your mercies and Your great kindnesses, please have compassion on all the deceased of Your people Israel. Especially upon those who lie in this courtyard of death,[1] for with You is the source of life, and may they always walk before the living,[D] and may their 5020R

[C]Or: "to the God who completes [what concerns] me" — This more literal translation preserves the ambiguity of the Hebrew, which could refer to God completing or perfecting matters related to the individual.

[A]Or: "for the living and for the dead" — The preposition 'עִם' could be interpreted as 'for' or 'on behalf of' in this context, suggesting God's kindness being extended toward both living and dead rather than necessarily accompanying them.

[B]Or: "O God of Being, God Eternal, LORD" — This alternative provides more accessible English equivalents that convey the theological meaning of these divine names rather than transliterating them. This might be preferable in contexts where readers are less familiar with Hebrew divine names and their mystical significance.

[C]Or: "may they continually move in the presence of the living" — This alternative captures the

[1]This unusual metaphor for a cemetery (חצר מוות) suggests a transitional space rather than a final destination, aligning with the book's central metaphor of 'crossing over' from one state to another.

[iii]This extension to the original psalm verse is significant, as it explicitly connects divine care to both the living and the dead, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's central theme that God's loving-kindness transcends the boundary between life and death.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 57:2-3 — In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses are repurposed for cemetery prayers, extending their meaning to include God's protection not only for the living but also for the dead. This adaptation reflects the book's central theme of divine care extending beyond death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok prayer formulas — The prayer exemplifies how Ma'avar Yabok adapts biblical verses into liturgical formulas that create a theological framework connecting the living and the dead under God's protection and care.

[v]The prayer begins with three divine names that appear in ascending order of manifestation in Kabbalistic thought: Ehyeh (the name God revealed to Moses at the burning bush, representing pure becoming), Yah (a contracted form of the Tetragrammaton used in liturgy), and YHVH (represented here by its pronunciation substitute). This combination would be understood as invoking God's mercy from multiple divine dimensions simultaneously.

[vi]The cemetery is described as a 'courtyard of death,' reflecting the kabbalistic understanding that burial grounds are not merely endpoints but transitional spaces—courtyards leading to other realms where the soul begins its journey after leaving the body.

[i]This phrase, derived from 1 Samuel 25:29, became the standard expression in Jewish tradition for describing the afterlife state of the righteous. Literally 'bound in the bundle of life,' it suggests souls being gathered together and preserved in God's special treasury. This phrase appears on many Jewish tombstones to this day.

[ii]Cf. Psalm 36:10 — This prayer draws on the biblical phrase from Psalms to connect God as the source of both physical and spiritual life. In the context of a cemetery prayer, it affirms that even the deceased remain connected to this divine source. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — This classic phrase from Samuel has become the central metaphor in Jewish tradition for the soul's continued existence after death. It expresses the hope that the departed souls remain connected to the divine source of eternal life. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4 — This phrase reflects Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of the cemetery as a liminal space between worlds—not merely a place of endings but a courtyard or transitional area where souls begin their journey to the next realm. | Cf. Divine Names: Ehyeh, Yah, YHVH — The prayer begins with three divine names that represent different aspects of God's manifestation. This triple invocation is characteristic of kabbalistic prayers that seek to draw upon multiple divine attributes simultaneously.

בִּצְרוֹר הַחַיִּים:[vi v] souls be bound in the bond of life.[2]

אֵל חַנּוּן כְּרוֹב חֲסָדָיו
וְרַחֲמָיו[i] יְרַחֵם עֲלֵיכֶם וּמִלְּפָנָיו
מִשְׁפָּטֵכֶם יֵצֵא[ii] וְעֵינָיו יֶחֱזֶינָה
4735 יוֹשֶׁר מַעֲשֵׂיכֶם הַטּוֹבִים וְתִחְיוּ
לְעוּמָתוֹ עִם כָּל נֶאֱמָנָיו וְתִזְכּוּ
לְהִתְהַלֵּךְ לְפָנָיו בְּאַרְצוֹת
הַחַיִּים.[iii] וְתָמִיד תִּתְהַלְּכוּ נֶגֶד

May the gracious God, according to His abundant kindness and mercy,[A] have compassion upon you. 5025R
May your judgment proceed from before Him,[1] and may His eyes behold the uprightness of your good deeds. May you stand before Him with all His faithful ones,[B] and may you merit to walk before Him in the lands of the living.[2] And may you always 5030R

continuous aspect of the Hebrew verb form and clarifies that the text is referring to an ongoing spiritual presence rather than a physical walking. It might be preferred in contexts where the metaphorical nature of the phrase needs to be emphasized.

[A]Or: "The gracious God, in the abundance of His loving-kindness and compassion," — This alternate translation is more literal in rendering the preposition 'כְּרוֹב' as 'in the abundance of' rather than 'according to.' It also translates 'רַחֲמָיו' as 'compassion' which might better capture the nuance of the Hebrew term related to womb-like mercy.

[B]Or: "May you be counted among all His faithful ones in His presence," — The Hebrew 'לְעוּמָתוֹ' literally means 'opposite to Him' or 'corresponding to Him,' which in this context implies being positioned in relation to God. The alternate translation captures the idea of being counted among the faithful in God's presence, which may better reflect the spiritual state being described.

[1]This traditional phrase (צרור החיים) has become the standard Jewish expression for the afterlife state of the righteous, appearing on countless tombstones with the Hebrew abbreviation ה.ב.צ.נ.ת (May his/her soul be bound in the bond of life).

[2]The Hebrew construction 'מִלְּפָנָיו מִשְׁפָּטֵכֶם יֵצֵא' literally means 'from before Him may your judgment go forth,' emphasizing that divine judgment originates directly from God's presence. This reflects the Jewish belief that souls are judged by God after death.

[3]In biblical Hebrew, 'to walk before God' is an idiom expressing living in accordance with divine will and enjoying divine favor. In this cemetery prayer context, this phrase has been transformed from its original meaning of living righteously in this world to describing the soul's existence in the afterlife.

[iii]This opening phrase invokes God specifically in His aspect of grace and mercy, appropriate for a cemetery prayer seeking divine compassion for the deceased. The Hebrew term 'רַחֲמָיו' (His mercy) derives from 'רֶחֶם' (womb), suggesting a maternal, nurturing quality to divine compassion.

[iv]This reflects the Jewish belief that souls face divine judgment after death. The phrase 'מִלְּפָנָיו' (from before Him) emphasizes that judgment comes directly from God's presence, suggesting its ultimate authority and fairness.

[i]The Hebrew plural 'lands of the living' rather than singular 'land' suggests multiple realms or dimensions of afterlife existence, possibly reflecting kabbalistic concepts of different spiritual worlds that the soul traverses after death.

[ii]Cf. Psalm 116:9 — The phrase 'lands of the living' in this prayer echoes Psalm 116:9, transforming what was originally a statement about walking before God in this life into a hope for the deceased to walk before God in the afterlife. This subtly reframes the biblical verse from describing earthly existence to describing a post-mortem spiritual existence. | Cf. Deuteronomy 30:15 — The conclusion of this prayer echoes Deuteronomy's pairing of 'good' and 'life,' but transforms what was originally presented as a choice in this world into an eternal state in the afterlife. This suggests that the deceased have now entered a realm where they perpetually experience the 'good and life' that they chose during their earthly existence. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Cemetery Prayer section — This prayer is part of a larger collection of cemetery prayers in Ma'avar Yabok that consistently use biblical allusions to reframe the deceased's state from one of death to one of continued spiritual existence. The prayer employs conventional biblical phrases about walking before God and experiencing divine judgment, but applies them to the deceased's postmortem experience.

[iv] :הַטּוֹב וְהַחַיִּים walk before goodness and life.[C]

4740 אֱלֹהִים חַיִּים [i]יִזְכּוֹר יִזְכּוֹר
אֶתְכֶם בְּטוֹב וּבְרַחֲמִים וְיַגִּיהַּ
אוֹרְכֶם וְיַקְיֵם בָּכֶם חֶזְיוֹן
מַאֲמָרוֹ בְּרִיתִי הָיְתָה אִתּוֹ הַשָּׁלוֹם
וְהַחַיִּים[ii] וְתָמִיד תִּתְהַלְכוּ נֶגֶד
4745 [iv iii]הַטּוֹב וְהַחַיִּים:

May the Living God[A] surely remember you[B 1] for good and with mercy, and may He cause your light to shine,[C] and fulfill in you the vision of His word:[D] "My covenant was with him, life and peace,"[2] and may you always walk before goodness and life. 5035R

[C]Or: "And may you perpetually journey in the presence of the Good and the Living One." — This alternate interpretation reads 'הַטּוֹב וְהַחַיִּים' not as abstract concepts (goodness and life) but as divine epithets referring to God as 'the Good' and 'the Living One.' This reading is plausible in the context of a prayer addressing the deceased's relationship with God in the afterlife, though it's less literal than the original translation.

[A]Or: "God of Life" — The phrase can be translated either way, with 'Living God' being more common in English liturgical language, while 'God of Life' emphasizes God as the source of life rather than as a living entity.

[B]Or: "remember, may He remember you" — The doubling of the verb root (zakor yizkor) creates emphasis in Hebrew. My original translation captures this through 'surely,' but the alternate translation preserves the repetitive structure of the original Hebrew.

[C]Or: "brighten your light" — The verb 'yagiha' comes from a root meaning to shine/brighten. The alternate translation is more concise while the original translation more explicitly indicates divine causation.

[D]Or: "and establish in you the vision of His utterance" — The terms 'yeqayem' (establish/fulfill) and 'ma'amaro' (His word/utterance) have multiple possible translations. The alternate translation uses more formal theological language.

[1]The Hebrew uses a doubled verb construction 'zachor yizkor' (literally 'remember, He will remember'), which is a grammatical form used for emphasis. I've translated this emphatic construction using 'surely' to convey the intensity of the original.

[2]This phrase is quoted from Malachi 2:5, where it refers to God's covenant with the priestly tribe of Levi. In the context of this cemetery prayer, it suggests that the deceased now shares in the special relationship of peace and life that characterized the priestly covenant.

[iii]The phrase 'Elohim Chayim' (Living God) appears frequently in cemetery prayers, emphasizing God's eternal nature in contrast to human mortality. This creates a theological framework where death is not an end but a transition into God's eternal presence.

[iv]This is a direct quotation from Malachi 2:5, referring to God's covenant with Levi. By invoking this priestly covenant in a cemetery prayer, the text creates a connection between the deceased and the divine service of the priests, suggesting that death is itself a form of sacred service.

[i]The Hebrew verb 'tithalchu' (you shall walk) shares the same root as 'halicha' (walking), which in Jewish mystical thought represents the soul's ongoing journey even after death. This phrase reflects the central metaphor of Ma'avar Yabok: death as a crossing or journey rather than an endpoint.

[ii]Cf. Malachi 2:5 — The cemetery prayer invokes God's covenant with Levi as a paradigm for the divine promises of life and peace that extend to the deceased. This reference connects the deceased to the priestly lineage and divine service. | Cf. Psalm 56:14 — The concluding phrase "may you always walk before goodness and life" echoes Psalm 56:14's "that I may walk before God in the light of life." This allusion transforms the biblical verse into a prayer for the deceased's soul to continue a spiritual journey in the divine presence. | Cf. Burial Kaddish — While not quoting the Kaddish directly, this cemetery prayer shares its structure of invoking divine attributes followed by expressions of hope for the deceased, reflecting the Jewish liturgical pattern of comfort prayers at graves.

[iii]This opening combines the Tetragrammaton with a reference to God as the deity of the patriarchs, establishing the prayer's connection to ancestral tradition and covenant.

יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי אֲבוֹת הָעוֹלָם[v] הַמִּתְפָּאֵר
בְּרֹב עוֹז וְתַעֲצוּמוֹת[vi] יָחוֹן עַל
כָּל אֶחָד מִכֶּם וְשַׁעֲרֵי שְׁמַיָּא יְהוּ
תָמִיד לְפָנֵיכֶם נִפְתָּחִים וּבְמִתִיבוֹת
4750 וּבְמִשְׁכָּנוֹת מַבְטָחִים[i] תִּזְכּוּ
לֵישֵׁב עִם מַלְאֲכֵי שָׁלוֹם. וְהַכֹּהֵן
הַגָּדוֹל יַעֲלֶה רֵיחַ נִיחוֹחֲכֶם
לְרָצוֹן.[ii] וְתָנוּחוּ וְתַעַמְדוּ לְקֵץ
הַיָּמִין:[iii iv]

The LORD God of the fathers of the world,[E] who glorifies Himself with abundant strength and might, may He be gracious to each one of you, and may the 5040R
gates of heaven always be open before you.[1] May you merit to dwell in academies and secure dwelling places[A 2] with the angels of peace. And may the High Priest offer up your pleasing fragrance with favor.[B] May you rest and arise at the end of days to 5045R
eternal life.[C]

[E] Or: "The LORD, God of the patriarchs of old" — This alternate translation emphasizes the biblical patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) rather than the more literal 'fathers of the world.' This might be preferable in contexts where the theological connection to the biblical patriarchs is more relevant than the chronological reference.

[A] Or: "in heavenly yeshivas and sanctuaries of refuge" — This alternate translation uses the more specific term 'yeshivas' for 'מְתִיבוֹת' (which specifically refers to rabbinic academies in the afterlife according to rabbinic literature) and renders 'מִשְׁכָּנוֹת מַבְטָחִים' with more spiritual connotations. This might be preferable in contexts emphasizing the mystical aspects of the afterlife.

[B] Or: "And may the celestial High Priest present your essence as a sweet offering" — This alternative emphasizes the metaphorical nature of the High Priest in this context, as the prayer refers to the afterlife where there is no literal Temple service. The 'pleasing fragrance' is rendered as 'essence' to convey that it represents the spiritual essence of the deceased rather than a literal fragrance.

[C] Or: "May you rest in peace and stand up at the resurrection of the dead" — This alternate translation more explicitly references the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection ('stand up' rather than 'arise') and uses the traditional phrase 'resurrection of the dead' rather than the more poetic 'end of days to eternal life.' This might be preferable in contexts where doctrinal clarity is prioritized over poetic expression.

[1] The original uses the Aramaic 'שְׁמַיָּא' for 'heaven' rather than the Hebrew 'שָׁמַיִם,' reflecting the influence of Aramaic in Jewish liturgical and mystical texts, particularly those dealing with the afterlife.

[2] I've translated 'מְתִיבוֹת' as 'academies' rather than the more specific 'yeshivas' to maintain accessibility while still conveying the concept of centers of Torah study in the afterlife. The phrase 'מִשְׁכָּנוֹת מַבְטָחִים' echoes Isaiah 32:18 and refers to heavenly abodes of peace and security.

[iv] This description of God glorifying Himself with strength and might echoes liturgical language from the daily prayers, particularly the Yishtabach blessing.

[v] The term 'מְתִיבוֹת' specifically refers to heavenly academies where souls continue studying Torah after death according to rabbinic tradition, while 'מִשְׁכָּנוֹת מַבְטָחִים' (secure dwelling places) evokes Isaiah 32:18.

[vi] This metaphor draws on Temple sacrifice language, comparing the acceptance of the deceased's soul to the High Priest's offering of sacrifices that were received with divine favor. The 'High Priest' here may refer metaphorically to the archangel Michael, who according to some rabbinic traditions serves as a celestial High Priest.

[i] This conclusion echoes Daniel 12:13, expressing the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection at the end of days. The paired verbs 'rest' and 'arise' encapsulate the Jewish understanding of death as a temporary sleep followed by awakening in the messianic era.

[ii] Cf. Song of Songs 4:11 — This reference frames the deceased as a pleasing offering to God, suggesting that their soul is being received favorably in heaven, much like sacrifices were accepted in the Temple. | Cf. Leviticus 1:9 — By employing Temple sacrifice terminology, the prayer creates a parallel between the acceptance of the deceased's soul in heaven and the acceptance of sacrifices in the Temple, implying that death itself serves as a form of atonement. | Cf. Daniel 12:13 — By echoing Daniel's prophecy about resurrection, the prayer affirms the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection and frames death as a temporary sleep from which the righteous will awaken in the messianic era. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 17a — This cemetery prayer follows a similar structure to rabbinic afterlife prayers found in the Talmud, emphasizing continued Torah study in heavenly academies (מְתִיבוֹת) and divine acceptance, reflecting the rabbinic conception of paradise as a place of continued spiritual growth rather than mere repose.

יְיָ צְבָאוֹת וֵאלֹהֵי צְבָאוֹת
יָחוֹן עֲלֵיכֶם. וְיִתְהַלֵּךְ עִמָּכֶם וּבְגַן
עֵדֶן תַּחְתּוֹן וְעֶלְיוֹן אַחַר עֲלוֹת
נִשְׁמַת כָּל אֶחָד מִכֶּם מִמְּעָרַת
הַמַּכְפֵּלָה לִכְרוּבִים.[i] וּמִשָּׁם אֵל
יִרְעֶה אֶתְכֶם וְשָׁם תִּחְיוּ וְתִתְעַדְּנוּ
וְתַעֲמְדוּ מִלְמַעְלָה וּלְמָרוֹם
תַּעֲלוּ[ii] מִדֵּי חֹדֶשׁ בְּחָדְשׁוֹ וּמִדֵּי
שַׁבָּת בְּשַׁבָּתוֹ לְהִשְׁתַּחֲווֹת לְפָנַי
הַמֶּלֶךְ יְיָ צְבָאוֹת וְתִזְכּוּ לַעֲמוֹד
לְקֵץ הַיָּמִים:[iii]

May the LORD of Hosts and God of Hosts have mercy upon you. May He walk with you[D] in both the lower and upper Garden of Eden after the ascent of each of your souls from the Cave of Machpelah to the Cherubim.[1] From there, God will shepherd you, and there you shall live and delight, and you shall stand above and ascend on high from one New Moon to another and from one Sabbath to another to bow down before the King, the LORD of Hosts,[2] and may you merit to stand at the end of days.[A][3]

שַׁדַּי מֶלֶךְ רַחֲמָן[iv] יִפְקֹד אֶתְכֶם

Shaddai, the merciful King,[4] will remember you for

[A] Or: "May He stroll with you" — The Hebrew 'yitayel' has connotations of a leisurely stroll or promenade rather than just walking. This alternate translation captures the sense of divine companionship in a more relaxed, intimate setting.

[B] Or: "the culmination of life" — While 'end of days' is the standard eschatological rendering, 'the culmination of life' might better capture the positive connotation of this phrase as the ultimate fulfillment of existence rather than simply its endpoint.

[1] This depicts a mystical geography of the afterlife, where souls travel from earthly burial sites (represented by the Cave of Machpelah where the Patriarchs are buried) to celestial realms (represented by the Cherubim who guard divine presence).

[2] This describes the ongoing spiritual activity of souls in the afterlife, specifically their participation in celestial worship ceremonies that mirror earthly liturgical cycles marked by the New Moon and Sabbath.

[3] This refers to the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection (techiyat ha-metim) at the end of days. The prayer expresses hope that the deceased will merit resurrection when the Messiah comes.

[4] The divine name Shaddai (שַׁדַּי) is traditionally associated with God's attribute of sufficient power and providence. In this context, it's paired with "merciful King" to emphasize the compassionate aspect of divine judgment in the afterlife.

[i] Shaddai (one of God's names meaning "Almighty") is here portrayed as a merciful king, consistent with the kabbalistic understanding of divine attributes combining power and compassion.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that souls continue to ascend through spiritual levels even after death, achieving progressively higher states of divine communion.

[iii] In kabbalistic thought, the Cave of Machpelah (the burial site of the biblical Patriarchs and Matriarchs) functions as a mystical waystation for souls, from which they ascend to higher spiritual realms represented by the Cherubim.

[iv] Cf. Isaiah 66:23 — This is a direct quote from Isaiah 66:23, which describes the regular worship of God in the messianic era. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse is applied to the souls of the deceased, suggesting they will participate in celestial worship according to the divine calendar, just as described in Isaiah's vision of the end times. | Cf. Cave of Machpelah — The Cave of Machpelah is the burial site of the biblical Patriarchs and Matriarchs (Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Rebecca, Jacob, and Leah). In kabbalistic thought, it represents both a physical burial place and a mystical waystation for souls. The reference suggests that souls first gather at this ancestral burial ground before ascending higher through the spiritual realms. | Cf. Zohar — The prayer's structure and imagery reflect concepts from the Zohar, particularly regarding the soul's posthumous journey through various celestial realms. The Zohar describes souls ascending from lower to higher levels in the afterlife, with righteous souls continuing to ascend on Sabbaths and New Moons to receive additional divine illumination. | Cf. Garden of Eden — In kabbalistic cosmology, the Garden of Eden is divided into lower and upper realms. The lower Garden of Eden (Gan Eden Tachton) is where souls first arrive after death, while the upper Garden of Eden (Gan Eden Elyon) is a higher spiritual realm reserved for the most spiritually accomplished souls. This prayer envisions the deceased ascending through both levels.

לְטוֹב. וְאַחַר פְּתִיחַת שַׁעֲרֵי הַמִּקְדָּשׁ עַל יְדֵי מִיכָאֵל[i] יוּקְרְבוּ נְשָׁמוֹת שֶׁנִּתְאַחֲדוּ[ii] לְבָנֵס אֶל הַקֹּדֶשׁ פְּנִימָה[iii] עַל יְדֵי הַשַּׂר הַגָּדוֹל[iv] וְיַעֲלוּ קָרְבָּן[v] לִפְנֵי הָאֵל וְיִתְלַוֶּה עִמָּהֶם הַמַּלְאָךְ הַגּוֹאֵל[vi] עַד שַׁעֲרֵי עֲרָבוֹת[vii] וְשָׁם תִּזְכּוּ לִנְעִימוֹת עַד קֵץ הַחַיִּים:[viii][ix]

good. And after the opening of the gates of the Sanctuary by Michael,[1] the souls that have united[2] will be brought to enter into the innermost sanctum by the Great Prince, and they will offer a sacrifice before God.[3] The Redeeming Angel will accompany them to the gates of Aravot,[4] and there you will merit pleasantness until the end of days.[5] 5060R

אֲדֹנָי מֶלֶךְ עוֹלָם[x] יְזַכֶּה נַפְשׁוֹת The Lord, King of the universe,[6] shall merit all your 5065R

[1]This reflects the Jewish mystical belief that Michael serves as the high priest in the celestial Temple, paralleling the role of the high priest in the earthly Temple who would enter the Holy of Holies.

[2]The Hebrew 'שֶׁנִּתְאַחֲדוּ' implies not just a gathering of souls but their unification in spiritual harmony, a state considered necessary for higher ascent in the afterlife journey.

[3]This is not a literal animal sacrifice but a metaphorical offering of the soul's essence and devotion, representing the culmination of the soul's spiritual service.

[4]Aravot (עֲרָבוֹת) is the highest of seven heavens in rabbinic and kabbalistic cosmology, where God's throne of glory, justice, and righteousness resides. This represents the ultimate destination in the soul's posthumous journey.

[5]The 'pleasantness' (נְעִימוֹת) refers to spiritual delight in the divine presence, and 'the end of days' (קֵץ הַחַיִּים) indicates this state continues until resurrection, when souls will return to renewed bodies.

[6]The Hebrew text begins with the divine name 'Adonai' followed by 'melech olam' (King of the universe/eternal King), establishing God's sovereignty over all realms, including the afterlife.

[i]In Jewish mystical tradition, the archangel Michael serves as the heavenly high priest who opens the gates of the celestial Temple for souls to enter after death.

[ii]This refers to souls that have achieved a state of unification or harmony, considered a prerequisite for entering higher spiritual realms.

[iii]The "innermost sanctum" parallels the Holy of Holies in the earthly Temple but refers here to the most sacred celestial realm where souls come into direct divine presence.

[iv]"The Great Prince" likely refers to the archangel Michael, who in Jewish tradition is considered the guardian of Israel and the high priest of the heavenly Temple.

[v]This metaphorically describes souls offering themselves as sacrifices before God, representing complete spiritual devotion and self-nullification in the divine presence.

[vi]"The Redeeming Angel" appears in Genesis 48:16 where Jacob blesses his grandchildren. In mystical contexts, it represents a specific angelic force that guides and protects souls in their afterlife journey.

[vii]Aravot is the seventh and highest heaven in Jewish mystical cosmology, considered the dwelling place of God's glory, divine presence, and throne.

[viii]"The end of days" refers to the messianic era and resurrection of the dead, indicating that the souls will remain in this pleasant state until the ultimate redemption and resurrection.

[ix]Cf. Genesis 48:16 — The text echoes Jacob's invocation of 'the angel who has redeemed me from all harm' (הַמַּלְאָךְ הַגֹּאֵל אֹתִי מִכָּל־רָע), applying it to the soul's posthumous journey. This creates a connection between ancestral blessing and afterlife protection. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The text draws on the Zohar's elaborate descriptions of the celestial realms, particularly Aravot as the seventh heaven where righteous souls experience divine pleasure. The entire passage presents a condensed version of the soul's ascent through heavenly palaces as described in Zoharic literature. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Hagigah 12b — The reference to Aravot as a celestial realm draws on the Talmud's description of the seven heavens, where Aravot is described as the highest heaven containing righteousness, justice, and God's throne of glory. | Cf. Isaiah 57:2 — The passage's emphasis on souls meriting pleasantness echoes Isaiah's description of peace for the righteous: 'He shall enter into peace; they shall rest in their beds, each one walking in his uprightness.' However, Ma'avar Yabok extends this concept with a more elaborate celestial journey.

[x]This opening employs the divine name Adonai (Lord) alongside the title 'King of the universe,' establishing the prayer's focus on God's sovereignty over both the living and the dead.

כְּלָכֶם עִם כָּל שִׁכְבֵי עַמּוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל
לִהְיוֹת צְרוּרוֹת בִּצְרוֹר הַחַיִּים
עִם רָאשֵׁי יְשִׁיבוֹת וְרָאשֵׁי גָּלִיּוֹת
4780 יִשְׂרָאֵל וְכֹהֲנִים וּלְוִיִּם וְעִם שֶׁבַע
כִּתּוֹת שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים וַחֲסִידִים[i] וְשָׁם
בְּגַן עֲדָנִים תָּנוּחוּ וְתַעֲמְדוּ לְקֵץ
הַחַיִּים וּלְקֵץ הַיָּמִין[ii] בְּדִרְכְתִיךְ
וְאַתָּה לֵךְ לְקֵץ וְתָנוּחַ וְתַעֲמֹד
4785 לְגוֹרָלְךָ לְקֵץ הַיָּמִין:[iii] שׁוֹמֵר
נַפְשׁוֹת חֲסִידָיו מִיַּד רְשָׁעִים
יַצִּילֵם: אוֹר זָרוּעַ לַצַּדִּיק וּלְיִשְׁרֵי

souls,[A] together with all the departed of His people Israel, to be bound in the bond of life with the heads of academies and the leaders of the exiles of Israel, and with priests and Levites, and with the seven classes of righteous and pious ones.[1] And there, in 5070R
the Garden of Delights,[B] may you rest and arise at the end of days and at the end of the right hand,[C] as it is written: "But you, go your way to the end; and you shall rest, and shall stand in your allotted place at the end of days." He preserves the souls of His 5075R
faithful ones; from the hand of the wicked He deliv-

[A] Or: "shall grant merit to all your souls" — This alternate translation more clearly expresses the causative aspect of the Hebrew verb 'yezakeh,' emphasizing that God is actively bestowing merit rather than the souls earning it themselves. This might be preferable in contexts where theological precision about divine agency is important.

[B] Or: "Garden of Eden" — While 'Garden of Delights' is a literal translation of 'Gan Adanim,' the term is commonly understood as referring to the Garden of Eden in its paradisiacal afterlife context. This more familiar translation might be preferable in contexts where the cultural reference is more important than the literal wording.

[C] Or: "and at the time of final redemption" — This alternate translation captures the eschatological meaning of the phrase rather than its literal wording. In kabbalistic thought, 'the right hand' represents God's attribute of mercy (Chesed), and 'the end of the right' refers to the final redemption that will come through divine mercy. This translation might be preferable in contexts where clarity of meaning is prioritized over literal rendering.

[1] This refers to a kabbalistic concept where the souls of the righteous are organized into seven distinct categories in the afterlife, each with its own level of spiritual attainment and corresponding heavenly dwelling place.

[iv] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of seven distinct categories of righteous souls in the Garden of Eden, each with its own level and dwelling place. These categories are variously enumerated in rabbinic literature, but typically include martyrs, those who died from illness, the perfectly righteous, etc.

[v] This phrase literally means 'to the end of the right' and is a kabbalistic reference to the sefirah of Chesed (loving-kindness), which is positioned on the right side of the sefirotic tree. It suggests that the resurrection will come through God's attribute of mercy rather than judgment.

[vi] This is a direct quotation from Daniel 12:13, where the angel tells Daniel about his fate after death. The verse has become central to Jewish understanding of resurrection and the afterlife.

[i] Cf. Daniel 12:13 — The citation of Daniel 12:13 explicitly connects this prayer to the Jewish belief in bodily resurrection. By invoking this verse, the prayer assures the deceased that their current rest is temporary, and they will ultimately 'stand in their allotted place'—be resurrected—at the end of days. | Cf. Psalm 97:11 — The citation of Psalm 97:11 at the prayer's conclusion reinforces the belief that the deceased righteous will experience divine illumination and joy in the afterlife, providing comfort to both the deceased and the mourners by emphasizing divine reward for righteousness. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — The phrase 'bound in the bond of life' (צְרוּרוֹת בִּצְרוֹר הַחַיִּים) is a direct allusion to 1 Samuel 25:29, where Abigail tells David that his soul will be 'bound in the bundle of life with the Lord your God.' In Jewish tradition, this became a central metaphor for the afterlife, representing the soul's secure preservation under divine protection after death. Its inclusion in this prayer affirms the belief that the deceased's soul continues to exist in a protected relationship with God. | Cf. Psalm 97:10 — This verse reinforces the theme of divine protection for the souls of the righteous, offering reassurance that God continues to guard the deceased from harmful spiritual forces even after death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This prayer exemplifies Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a transition rather than an end. It integrates kabbalistic concepts (the seven classes of the righteous), biblical citations, and Jewish eschatology (resurrection at 'the end of days') to provide a comprehensive vision of the soul's journey after death. The prayer articulates the book's central purpose: to facilitate the soul's successful passage from this world to the next.

[iv] לֵב שִׂמְחָה׃

ers them. Light is sown for the righteous,[2] and joy for the upright in heart.

[i] תפלה אחרת על הקבר

Another prayer to be recited at the grave[1]

רִבּוֹן כָּל הָעוֹלָמִים מֶלֶךְ מַלְכֵי הַמְּלָכִים תִּמְחוֹל וְתִסְלַח עַל כָּל עֲוֹנוֹתַי וּתְכַפֵּר לִי עַל כָּל פְּשָׁעַי וּבְרָא לִי לֵב טָהוֹר וְטוֹב וְתֵן בְּלִבִּי אַהֲבָתְךָ וְיִרְאָתְךָ וְכוֹף אֶת יִצְרִי לְהִשְׁתַּעְבֵּד לָךְ וַהֲכָנֵע עֶרְפִּי לָשׁוּב אֵלֶיךָ וְתַצִּילֵנִי מֵעֲבֵרוֹת וּמֵהַרְהוּרִים רָעִים וְתִגְבַּר לִי יֵצֶר טוֹב עַל יֵצֶר הָרָע וּפְתַח לִבִּי לְתוֹרָתֶךָ וְדַבֵּק לִבִּי לַעֲסוֹק בָּהּ וְאֶהְיֶה בְּיוֹם מִיתָתִי כְּיוֹם לִידָתִי שֶׁלֹּא יִמָּצֵא בִּי שׁוּם חֵטְא וְעָוֹן.[ii] וְתֵן בְּלִבִּי כֹּחַ לִשְׁמוֹר פִּקּוּדֶיךָ וּתְזַכֵּנִי לִרְאוֹת בְּבִיאַת הַגּוֹאֵל וְכָתְבֵנִי בְּסֵפֶר הַחַיִּים בְּזֶה יוֹם הַדִּין[iii] וְחַדֵּשׁ עָלַי שָׁנָה טוֹבָה וּשְׁלַח בְּרָכָה בְּכָל מַעֲשֵׂי יָדַי וְתִקְצוֹב מְזוֹנוֹתַי וּתְפַרְנְסֵנִי בְּרֶוַח מִתַּחַת יָדֶיךָ וְלֹא מִתַּחַת בָּשָׂר וָדָם וּזְקוֹף קַרְנִי לְמַעְלָה וְתַגְבִּיהַּ מַזָּלִי וּתְנֵנִי לְחֵן וּלְחֶסֶד וּלְרַחֲמִים בְּעֵינֶיךָ וּבְעֵינֵי כָּל

Master of all Worlds, King of Kings, may You forgive and pardon all my iniquities and atone for all my transgressions. Create for me a pure and good heart, and instill within my heart Your love and reverence. Subdue my inclination to serve You,[2] humble my stubbornness to return to You, and save me from sins and evil thoughts. Strengthen my good inclination over my evil inclination and open my heart to Your Torah. Attach my heart to engage in it, so that on the day of my death I may be like the day of my birth—without any sin or iniquity found in me.

Grant my heart the strength to keep Your commandments and privilege me to witness the coming of the Redeemer. Inscribe me in the Book of Life on this Day of Judgment[3] and renew upon me a good year. Send blessing upon all the works of my hands, allot my sustenance, and provide for me abundantly from Your hands rather than from flesh and blood. Raise my stature, elevate my fortune,[4] and grant me grace, kindness, and mercy in Your eyes and in the eyes of all who behold me.

By the merit of [name] and by the merit of all

[2]This concluding verse from Psalm 97:11 reinforces the prayer's emphasis on divine reward and illumination for the righteous in the afterlife, providing comfort to both the deceased and the mourners.

[1]This is a heading or title for one of several prayer texts in Ma'avar Yabok intended for recitation at gravesites. The phrase 'תפלה אחרת' (another prayer) indicates this is part of a sequence of multiple prayers for cemetery use.

[2]The Hebrew phrase "וְכוֹף אֶת יִצְרִי לְהִשְׁתַּעְבֵּד לָךְ" literally means "bend my inclination to be subjugated to You." This reflects the Jewish concept of the yetzer (inclination) that needs to be directed toward divine service.

[3]This language is borrowed from High Holiday liturgy, specifically Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur prayers, though here it's adapted for use in a cemetery prayer context.

[1]The Hebrew term "מַזָּלִי" (mazali) refers to one's astrological fortune or destiny. In rabbinic literature, while astrology is often viewed skeptically, the concept of mazal as divine influence on one's life was widely accepted.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is a section heading for one of several different prayer texts provided in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation at graves. The text follows other grave prayers and precedes additional cemetery-related liturgy, indicating it belongs to a collection of prayers designed for cemetery visitation.

[iii]This reference to being "like the day of my birth—without any sin" draws on the rabbinic concept that a newborn is without sin, and connects to the idea that death, when approached properly, can be a form of spiritual purification like birth.

[i]The phrase "on this Day of Judgment" suggests this prayer could be intended for recitation during the High Holy Days (particularly Rosh Hashanah or Yom Kippur), but the context indicates it is part of a cemetery prayer that incorporates language from various liturgical contexts.

רוֹאֵי בְּזְכוּת פְּלוּנִי וּבְזְכוּת
כָּל הַצַּדִּיקִים[i] וּזְכוּתוֹ וְצִדְקָתוֹ
וּמַעֲשָׂיו הַטּוֹבִים יָגֵן וְיָלִיץ בַּעֲדִי
4815 וְתַעֲשֶׂה בַּקָּשָׁתִי וּמַלֹּא כָּל מִשְׁאֲלוֹת
לִבִּי לְטוֹבָה וְאַל תְּשִׁיבֵנִי רֵיקָם
מִלְּפָנֶיךָ:[ii]

the righteous ones, may his merit, righteousness, and good deeds protect and advocate for me.[1] Fulfill my request and satisfy all the desires of my heart for good, and do not turn me away empty-handed from 5105R
before You.

[iii]וכשיצא מבית הקברות יאמר

And when one leaves the cemetery,[2] one should say:

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי
4820 אֲבוֹתַי כָּל מַה שֶּׁבִּקַּשְׁתִּי לְפָנֶיךָ
יִהְיֶה בְּעֵינֶיךָ כִּקְטוֹרֶת[iv] וְתַעֲשֶׂה
עִמִּי לְפָנִים מִשּׁוּרַת הַדִּין[v] וְאַתָּה
רַחֲמָן שׁוֹמֵעַ בְּרָצוֹן תְּפִלַּת עַבְדֶּךָ
וּבַעֲבוּר זֶה בָּאתִי לְפָנֶיךָ כִּי
4825 אֵין לִי מֵלִיץ לְהָלִיץ בַּעֲדִי
לְפָנֶיךָ וְנָא אַל תְּשִׁיבֵנוּ רֵיקָם
מִלְּפָנֶיךָ כִּי אַתָּה שׁוֹמֵעַ תְּפִלָּה

May it be Your will, O LORD my God and God of my fathers, that everything I have requested before You be regarded in Your eyes like incense,[3] and 5110R
may You deal with me beyond the strict measure of judgment.[4] You, O Merciful One, willingly hear the prayer of Your servant, and for this reason I have come before You, for I have no advocate to plead on my behalf before You. Please do not turn us away 5115R
empty-handed from Your presence,[5] for You hear

[2]The Hebrew term "וְיָלִיץ" (ve-yalitz) comes from the root meaning "to intercede" or "advocate," and carries a specific legal connotation in rabbinic literature, suggesting representation before the heavenly court.

[3]In Jewish tradition, there are specific prayers and rituals associated with leaving a cemetery, including washing one's hands without blessing and reciting certain verses. This instruction introduces one such prayer that should be recited at the moment of departure from the burial grounds.

[4]The Hebrew term 'ketoret' specifically refers to the sacred incense offering prepared according to a divinely prescribed formula and burned in the ancient Temple. This connection between prayer and Temple ritual is a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok.

[5]This is a technical term in Jewish theology (lifnim mishurat hadin) referring to divine conduct that transcends strict justice to incorporate mercy and compassion. In the context of cemetery prayers, it's a particularly appropriate request, as Jewish tradition views death as a time when divine mercy is especially needed.

[1]The imagery of not returning empty-handed from God's presence draws on biblical imagery of pilgrims bringing offerings to the Temple and not appearing 'empty-handed' before God (Exodus 23:15). In this cemetery prayer, the petitioner asks that their spiritual pilgrimage to the graves of the righteous similarly result in divine blessing.

[ii]The practice of invoking the merit of the righteous (זכות צדיקים) at gravesites reflects the belief that the deceased righteous can intercede on behalf of the living, a concept that gained prominence in medieval Jewish mysticism.

[iii]Cf. Psalms 51:12 — The prayer draws on penitential language from Psalms, particularly those attributed to King David, connecting personal repentance with preparation for death. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:5 — By incorporating language from the central Jewish prayer of faith, the supplication connects deathbed piety with lifelong devotion to God. | Cf. Rosh Hashanah liturgy — The prayer creates a parallel between the annual judgment of Rosh Hashanah and the final judgment at death, suggesting similar spiritual preparation is needed for both. | Cf. Psalm 20:5-6 — This creates a connection between the personal prayer at a gravesite and the communal prayers for divine assistance found in Psalms.

[iv]This short instruction appears in Ma'avar Yabok after a series of prayers to be recited at the graveside. It introduces a prayer to be said specifically when departing from the cemetery.

[v]The comparison of prayer to incense (ketoret) refers to the Temple incense offering, which had purifying and protective spiritual properties. In Ma'avar Yabok, this metaphor appears frequently, especially in the section titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer), which explores how words of prayer create metaphysical effects similar to the ancient Temple service.

[i]This phrase literally means 'inside the line of judgment' and refers to divine conduct that goes beyond strict justice to incorporate mercy. In the context of cemetery prayers, it's a request that God judge the deceased with mercy rather than strict justice.

בַּעֲבוּר כָּל הַצַּדִּיקִים הַשּׁוֹכְנִים בְּכָאן [i] וּבַעֲבוּר תִּפְאַרְתְּךָ הַגָּדוֹל
4830 בָּרוּךְ שׁוֹמֵעַ תְּפִלָּה. יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי: נשלמו תפלות על הקברים [iii] [ii]

prayer for the sake of all the righteous ones who rest here and for the sake of Your great glory. Blessed are You who hears prayer. May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before 5120R
You, O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer. Thus conclude the prayers at the graves.[1]

תפלה שלוחה מירושלים
4835 [v] [iv] תוב״ב

Prayer sent from Jerusalem, may it be rebuilt and established[A]

דרכי שמרתי במעירי שחר שלי ואותה אשמור וממנה לא אטה להמתיק בפי הרבים תחנות ובקשות וקינות מאנשי
4840 מדע והחכמה ומכריסן של ראשונים כי הקשורים ליעקב הם המעוררים ישראל סבא עם תבונה ובפרט מאותם אשר נתפשטו באויר המחכים בארץ
4845 ישראל ובירושלים עיר הקדש ולהיות כי תפלה זו שהיא תקון קדמונים שקצת ממנה

I have maintained my path in my “Illuminators of 5125R
Dawn” prayer collection and I will continue to preserve it, never deviating from my practice of sharing with the public supplications, petitions, and lamentations from people of knowledge and wisdom and from the traditions of our forefathers. For those 5130R
connected to Jacob are the ones who awaken the ancient Israel with understanding, especially those whose teachings have spread in the enlightening atmosphere of the Land of Israel and Jerusalem, the Holy City. And since this prayer, which is an an- 5135R
cient spiritual remedy, part of which has been hid-

[A] Or: “Prayer dispatched from Jerusalem, may it be rebuilt and reestablished speedily in our days” — This more expansive translation unpacks the full traditional blessing contained in the תוב״ב acronym, which might be preferable for readers unfamiliar with this convention in Jewish texts.

[2] This final line is not part of the prayer itself but an editorial note marking the end of the cemetery prayer section in Ma’avar Yabok. Such structural markers appear throughout the text and help organize its extensive liturgical content.

[ii] This refers to the righteous individuals buried in the cemetery. Ma’avar Yabok consistently presents the merit of the righteous dead as a basis for divine favor, reflecting the Jewish belief that the deceased maintain spiritual influence and can intercede on behalf of the living.

[iii] This line is not part of the prayer itself but a scribal or editorial note indicating the conclusion of the section on cemetery prayers in Ma’avar Yabok.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 141:2 — The text opens by connecting the petitioner’s prayer to the Temple incense offering, a theme that appears throughout Ma’avar Yabok, particularly in its fourth section titled ‘Eter Anan HaKetoret’ (Cloud of Incense Prayer). | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok, Section 5 (Eter Anan HaKetoret) — This prayer appears at the conclusion of a section on cemetery prayers and reflects the book’s consistent theme that prayer serves as a spiritual substitute for Temple sacrifices, particularly the ketoret (incense) offering. | Cf. Psalm 19:14 — This direct quotation from Psalm 19:14 is commonly used to conclude Jewish prayers. In the context of cemetery prayers, it takes on additional significance as a petition that one’s words on behalf of the deceased be accepted. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 16b — This sentiment echoes Talmudic discussions about the individual’s direct relationship with God in prayer, particularly in moments of vulnerability like visiting graves where no intermediary can fully represent one’s personal petition.

[v] This is an acronym for ‘תִּבָּנֶה וְתִכּוֹנֵן בִּמְהֵרָה בְיָמֵינוּ’ (may it be rebuilt and established speedily in our days), a traditional phrase appended to mentions of Jerusalem after its destruction, expressing hope for its restoration.

[vi] Cf. Ma’avar Yabok — The subsequent passage explains that the author received an ancient prayer text from Jerusalem that he is now publishing. This heading indicates that what follows is that Jerusalem prayer, suggesting it carries special authority or efficacy.

היתה כמוסה מאז באוצרותי
עתה מחדש נשתלחה מקהלה
4850 קדושה אשר בירושלים תוב״ב
בגלילות אלו והודרכה אלי
תכף מבוסי״טו למען אזכה בה
רבים כאשר הודות לאל עשיתי
כי שלחתיה בכל סביבות אלו.
4855 רחש לבי ג״כ להדפיסה פה למען
נהיה גם אנו נאחדים עמהם[i] כי
המרובים העושים את המצוה
רוח פיהם יחשב קטרת:[iii] [ii]

den until now in my treasuries, has recently been sent from the holy congregation in Jerusalem (may it be rebuilt and established speedily in our days) to these regions and was immediately forwarded to me 5140R
from Bosetto so that I might benefit many people with it—as indeed, thanks to God, I have done by sending it throughout all these surrounding areas—
my heart has also been moved to print it here so that we too may be united with them, for when many join 5145R
together in performing a commandment, the breath of their mouths is considered like incense.

ואלה הם דבריהם אלינו[v] [iv]

And these are their words to us[1]

4860 ידוע מה שאמרו רז״ל שישראל
כפרו בשי״ת ובדוד מלכם ובבית
המקדש וצריך שיבקשו רחמים
על שלשתן והובא בילקוט
שמואל רמז י״ו[vi] בשם ר׳ סימון:

It is well-known that our Sages of blessed memory said that Israel denied the Holy One, blessed be He, 5150R
and David their king, and the Holy Temple,[2] and they need to seek mercy for all three. This is cited in Yalkut Shimoni, Samuel, hint 16, in the name of

[1] This phrase marks the beginning of material sent from Jerusalem to the author of Ma'avar Yabok. It introduces a prayer that follows, establishing its provenance as coming directly from the Holy City, which gives the prayer special authority in Jewish tradition.

[1] This triple denial is a significant theological concept in rabbinic thought. It relates to various sins throughout Jewish history: the denial of God through idol worship, the rejection of the Davidic monarchy (symbolizing messianic hope), and the desecration or neglect of the Temple. These three denials are understood to have led to exile and continued suffering.

[i] The author emphasizes the spiritual power of collective prayer and ritual, believing that when many people join together in performing a commandment or prayer, their unified intention creates a greater spiritual effect.

[ii] This metaphor comparing the breath of prayer to incense connects to both biblical traditions (where prayers are likened to incense in Psalms) and to Ma'avar Yabok itself, which has a section titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer) focusing on prayer as a spiritual substitute for Temple sacrifices.

[iii] Cf. Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) — The author is referencing his own prayer collection as the source of his established practices regarding what prayers to share with the public. This collection was evidently used by a prayer society in Modena that gathered for morning prayers. | Cf. Jerusalem as center of Jewish spiritual authority — The author is invoking the traditional Jewish concept that the air of the Land of Israel makes one wise ('avira d'Eretz Yisrael machkim'), giving special authority to prayers and religious texts that originate there. | Cf. Prayer as incense — This alludes to the biblical concept that prayers are like incense rising before God, as expressed in Psalm 141:2: 'May my prayer be set before you like incense.' This is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as one section of the book is titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer).

[iv] This phrase appears at the beginning of a letter or document from Jerusalem that introduces a prayer text. The phrase marks a transition from the author's introduction to the quoted content from Jerusalem.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, author's introduction — Throughout Ma'avar Yabok, the author frequently introduces materials from other sources, especially those with special religious authority. This phrase introduces content specifically from Jerusalem, which would have carried particular weight as coming from the Holy City.

[i] Yalkut Shimoni is a medieval midrashic compilation. The reference here is to a passage found in its commentary on the book of Samuel, where Rabbi Simon teaches that Israel needs to seek mercy for denying God, King David, and the Temple.

ואע״פ שאנו מבקשים על שלשתם
בתפלתנו אין לנו תפלה מיוחדת
על ככה ראוי ליראי ה׳ ולחושבי
שמו להתפלל על ג׳ אלה ורחמים
למבעי מן קדם אלהא שמיא על
רזא דנא[i] והתודו את עונם
ואת עון אבותם במעלם אשר
מעלו בו. על זה סדרנו תפלה
קצרה להתפלל אותה באשמורת
הבוקר כי אז שערי רחמים
פתוחים או בעת מנחת ערב
אחר תפלתם ותפלה זו קצתה
הועתקה מתפלת ראש השנה
וקצתה מפרקי היכלות[ii] וככה
יעשה יתנפל לפני אלהיו ויבכה
על עונות נעוריו ויתודה עוונותיו
ועון אבותיו אחרי שישוב אל
אלהיו בלבב שלם: [iii]

Rabbi Simon. Although we pray for these three in our regular prayers, we do not have a prayer specifically dedicated to this matter. It is fitting for those who fear God and think upon His name to pray concerning these three things and to seek mercy from the God of Heaven regarding this mystery, and to confess their iniquity and the iniquity of their fathers in the trespass which they committed against Him. 5155R 5160R

For this purpose, we have arranged a short prayer to be recited during the morning watch, when the gates of mercy are open,[1] or at the time of the evening offering after their regular prayers. Parts of this prayer have been adapted from the Rosh Hashanah liturgy and parts from Pirkei Heichalot. One should practice it thus: prostrate before your God,[2] weep over the sins of your youth, and confess your sins and the sins of your fathers after returning to your God with a whole heart. 5165R 5170R

קודם שיאמר תפלה זו מה
טוב ומה נעים שיפריש פרוטה
לצדקה בשם כל ישראל ויאמר
בפיו הנני נותן פרוטה זו לצדקה
לשם כל ישראל. ובזה יהיה

Before reciting this prayer, how good and pleasant it is[3] to set aside a coin for charity in the name of all Israel, and to say aloud, “I hereby give this coin to charity in the name of all Israel.” Through this act, one becomes among those who bring merit to the 5175R

[2] Jewish mystical tradition identifies specific times when divine mercy is especially accessible. The morning watch (the last third of the night before dawn) is considered particularly favorable for prayers of supplication and forgiveness.

[3] The Hebrew term יתנפל (yitnapel) has connotations beyond mere physical prostration—it suggests throwing oneself down in complete submission and desperate supplication. This intensifies the penitential character of the prayer being described.

[1] This phrase echoes Psalms 133:1, “Behold, how good and pleasant it is for brothers to dwell together in unity,” connecting the individual charitable act to communal harmony.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means “this mystery” or “this secret matter” and appears frequently in mystical texts. Its use here signals that the denial of God, David, and the Temple has profound mystical significance beyond simple historical events.

[iii] Pirkei Heichalot (Chapters of the Palaces) is an early Jewish mystical text from the Merkavah mystical tradition, focusing on ascent through heavenly palaces toward the divine throne. Incorporating elements from this text suggests this prayer has mystical dimensions beyond simple petition.

[i] Cf. Yalkut Shimoni on Samuel — This midrashic text is cited as the theological basis for the prayer being introduced, establishing why repentance for these three specific denials is necessary. | Cf. Pirkei Heichalot — The author states that portions of the prayer have been adapted from this mystical text, suggesting the prayer incorporates mystical elements focused on heavenly structures and divine attributes. | Cf. Rosh Hashanah liturgy — The author acknowledges borrowing elements from the Rosh Hashanah prayers, which focus on themes of repentance, divine sovereignty, and judgment—all relevant to the theological concerns being addressed. | Cf. Leviticus 26:40 — The phrase “confess their iniquity and the iniquity of their fathers” echoes this verse from Leviticus, establishing biblical precedent for transgenerational confession.

[ii] This phrase references Daniel 12:3 where “those who lead many to righteousness will shine like the stars forever.” By giving charity on behalf of all Israel, one elevates the entire community and is counted among those who bring merit to the many.

ממצדיקי הרבים[iv] ויעשה כל
ישראל בעלי צדקה. ובצדקה
4890 יכון כסא[i] ותופע עליו נהרה
ויפרוש שדי[ii] עלינו זיו הודו
והדרו ונגילה ונשמחה בישועתו.
ואחר כך יאמר:[iii]

many[4] and makes all Israel into charitable givers. Through charity the throne is established,[1] radiance shines upon it, and may Shaddai spread over us the splendor of His glory and majesty, that we may rejoice and be glad in His salvation. After this, one should say: 5180R

אָנָּא יְיָ חָטָאתִי עָוִיתִי
4895 פָּשַׁעְתִּי[iv] לְפָנֶיךָ אֲנִי וּבֵיתִי
אָנָּא יְיָ אֱלֹהַי כַּפֶּר נָא לַחֲטָאִים
וְלַעֲוֹנוֹת וְלַפְּשָׁעִים שֶׁחָטָאתִי
וְשֶׁעָוִיתִי וְשֶׁפָּשַׁעְתִּי לְפָנֶיךָ כַּכָּתוּב
אָנֹכִי אָנֹכִי הוּא מוֹחֶה פְּשָׁעֶיךָ
4900 לְמַעֲנִי[v] וְחַטֹּאתֶיךָ לֹא אֶזְכֹּר.
וְנֶאֱמַר מָחִיתִי כָעָב פְּשָׁעֶיךָ

Please LORD, I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled before You,[2] I and my household. Please LORD my God, forgive the sins, the iniquities, and the transgressions that I have sinned, transgressed, and rebelled before You, as it is written: "I, even I, am He who blots out your transgressions for My own sake,[3] and your sins I will not remember." And it is said: "I have blotted out, like a thick cloud, 5185R 5190R

[2]The Hebrew phrase "matzdikey ha-rabbim" comes from Daniel 12:3 and refers to those who cause many others to become righteous. Here it suggests that by giving charity on behalf of all Jews, one causes the entire community to fulfill the commandment of charity.

[3]This reflects the kabbalistic concept that human charitable actions have cosmic significance, literally establishing and supporting God's heavenly throne.

[4]I've maintained the traditional tripartite confession formula which represents increasing levels of intentional wrongdoing in Jewish thought. These three Hebrew terms have slightly different connotations that aren't fully captured in English: חטא (sin) can mean missing the mark or unintentional error; עון (transgression) implies knowingly doing wrong; and פשע (rebellion) suggests deliberate defiance of divine will.

[1]The doubling of 'I' (אָנֹכִי אָנֹכִי) in the Hebrew creates an emphasis that I've tried to capture with 'I, even I' in English. This emphasizes that forgiveness comes from God's initiative rather than human merit.

[iii]This alludes to Proverbs 16:12, "The throne is established through righteousness." In Jewish mystical thought, charitable acts have cosmic significance in establishing and supporting the divine throne.

[iv]Shaddai is one of the divine names of God, often associated with God's protective and nurturing aspects. It appears on mezuzot and is traditionally understood as an acronym for "Guardian of the Doors of Israel."

[v]Cf. Proverbs 16:12 — The text draws on Proverbs 16:12 which states that a throne is established through righteousness (צדקה), adapting it to emphasize the power of charitable giving to establish divine favor and cosmic order. | Cf. Daniel 12:3 — The phrase "those who bring merit to the many" (מצדיקי הרבים) directly references Daniel 12:3 which speaks of "those who lead many to righteousness" (מצדיקי הרבים) shining like stars forever. This connects the simple act of giving charity on behalf of others with the profound cosmic reward described in Daniel. | Cf. Psalms 21:6 — The passage echoes Psalms 21:6 which speaks of glory, splendor and majesty being placed upon the king/righteous person. Here it's adapted to describe divine attributes being spread over the community through the merit of charitable giving.

[i]This is the traditional tripartite confession formula in Jewish liturgy, particularly associated with Yom Kippur. The three terms represent increasingly severe categories of wrongdoing: חטא (chet) refers to missing the mark or sinning unintentionally; עון (avon) indicates conscious wrongdoing; and פשע (pesha) represents deliberate rebellion or transgression against God.

[ii]This is a direct quotation from Isaiah 43:25, highlighting God's promise to forgive sins for His own sake rather than because of human merit. The repetition of 'אָנֹכִי' (I) emphasizes divine initiative in forgiveness.

[iii]This quote from Isaiah 44:22 employs the metaphor of clouds being dispersed to represent the complete removal of sins, suggesting that divine forgiveness is thorough and leaves no trace of previous transgressions.

וְכֶעָנָן חַטֹּאתֶיךָ[vi] שׁוּבָה אֵלַי כִּי גְאַלְתִּיךָ:[i]

your transgressions, and like a cloud, your sins.[4] Return to Me, for I have redeemed you."

(תהלים קל) שִׁיר הַמַּעֲלוֹת
4905 מִמַּעֲמַקִּים קְרָאתִיךָ יְיָ:[ii] אֲדֹנָי
שִׁמְעָה בְקוֹלִי תִּהְיֶינָה אָזְנֶיךָ
קַשֻּׁבוֹת לְקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי: אִם עֲוֹנוֹת
תִּשְׁמָר יָהּ[iii] אֲדֹנָי מִי יַעֲמֹד: כִּי
עִמְּךָ הַסְּלִיחָה לְמַעַן תִּוָּרֵא: קִוִּיתִי
4910 יְיָ קִוְּתָה נַפְשִׁי וְלִדְבָרוֹ הוֹחָלְתִּי:
נַפְשִׁי לַאדֹנָי מִשֹּׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר
שֹׁמְרִים לַבֹּקֶר:[iv] יַחֵל יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶל

(Psalm 130) A Song of Ascents. From the depths I have called You, O LORD.[A] Lord, hear my voice; let Your ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications. If You, O LORD, should mark iniquities,[1] O Lord, who could stand? But with You there is forgiveness, that You may be feared.[2] I wait for the LORD, my soul waits, and for His word I hope. My soul longs for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning, watchmen for the morning.[B] Let Is- 5195R 5200R

[A]Or: "Out of the depths I cry to You, O LORD" — This alternative translation emphasizes the present tense and ongoing nature of the cry for help, which might be more appropriate in a contemporary liturgical context where the psalm is being actively recited by someone in distress.

[A]Or: "My soul [waits] for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning, more than watchmen for the morning" — The Hebrew doesn't contain an explicit verb between 'my soul' and 'for the Lord,' so 'waits' could be supplied instead of 'longs' to maintain consistency with the previous verse's emphasis on waiting. This creates a stronger connection between the verses and emphasizes the theme of patient anticipation.

[2]The Hebrew uses two different terms for 'cloud': 'עב' (thick cloud or rain cloud) and 'ענן' (standard cloud), which I've tried to preserve in translation. The metaphor suggests complete erasure, as clouds disperse and leave no trace.

[3]The Hebrew "tishmor" (should mark/keep track of) carries connotations of keeping a record or account. The verse acknowledges the impossibility of standing before divine judgment if God were to maintain a ledger of human sins, which connects directly to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession and spiritual preparation before death.

[1]The Hebrew phrase "lema'an tivare'" suggests that divine forgiveness paradoxically increases reverence or awe toward God rather than diminishing it. This theological point aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's presentation of death as both fearsome and potentially redemptive when approached with proper spiritual preparation.

[iv]Cf. Isaiah 43:25 — The prayer quotes this verse from Isaiah where God promises to forgive sins, using it as a scriptural basis for requesting divine forgiveness. This verse is a cornerstone of Jewish penitential liturgy. | Cf. Isaiah 44:22 — This second Isaiah verse reinforces the theme of divine forgiveness using the metaphor of clouds being dispersed, suggesting complete removal of sins. Its inclusion strengthens the supplicant's appeal by citing multiple divine promises of forgiveness. | Cf. Yom Kippur liturgy — The tripartite confession formula 'I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled' (חטאתי עויתי פשעתי) is a standard element in Jewish confessional prayers, particularly central to Yom Kippur liturgy. Its use here connects this prayer to established patterns of Jewish penitence. | Cf. Vidui (confession) prayers — The prayer follows the traditional structure of Jewish vidui (confession), beginning with the address to God (אנא י״י) followed by the triple confession formula. This would be recognizable to the reader as part of the established pattern of Jewish penitential prayer, particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok's focus on end-of-life spiritual preparation.

[v]This psalm, known as "De Profundis" from its Latin translation, is traditionally recited in times of distress and appears in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences for the sick and dying. The Hebrew phrase "from the depths" (mimaamakim) can be understood both literally as depths of physical distress and metaphorically as the depths of spiritual anguish.

[i]This verse is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of deathbed rituals, as it acknowledges human imperfection while expressing hope in divine forgiveness. The confession (vidui) prayers in the book similarly balance acknowledgment of sin with trust in divine mercy.

[ii]The repetition of "watchmen for the morning" creates a poetic emphasis that conveys intense longing. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this resonates with the deathbed vigil where attendants watch over the dying person, awaiting a transition that brings both trepidation and hope.

יְיָ כִּי עִם יְיָ חַסְדָּ וְהַרְבֵּה עִמּוֹ פְּדוּת: וְהוּא יִפְדֶּה אֶת יִשְׂרָאֵל מִכֹּל עֲוֹנֹתָיו:[i][ii]

rael hope in the LORD, for with the LORD there is loving-kindness, and with Him is abundant redemption.[1] And He will redeem Israel from all his iniquities.[A] 5205R

ואח״כ יחזור ויתודה ויאמר[iii][iv]

And after that he shall return and confess and say:[BC]

אָנָּא יְיָ חָטָאנוּ אֲנַחְנוּ וַאֲבוֹתֵינוּ הֶעֱוִינוּ וְהִרְשָׁעְנוּ וְכָפַרְנוּ בֵּאלָהוּתֶךָ וּבְדָוִד מַלְכֶּךָ וּבְבֵית קָדְשֶׁךָ וְתִפְאַרְתֶּךָ וְאָמַרְנוּ אֵין לָנוּ חֵלֶק בְּדָוִד וְלֹא נַחֲלָה בְּבֶן יִשַׁי אִישׁ לְאָהָלוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל עַתָּה

Please, O LORD, we and our ancestors have sinned, we have done wrong, we have acted wickedly, and we have denied Your divinity, Your king David, and Your holy and glorious Temple.[2] We said, "We have no part in David, nor inheritance in the son of Jesse. To your tents, O Israel!" Now we have returned, 5210R

[B]Or: "And He Himself will redeem Israel from all its iniquities" — Adding 'Himself' emphasizes the personal divine action in redemption, and changing 'his' to 'its' clarifies that the iniquities belong to the collective Israel rather than to God. However, the Hebrew can be legitimately read either way, and traditional interpretations often maintain the personal pronoun.

[C]Or: "Then he should repeat the confession and recite:" — This alternate translation is more concise and captures the practical instruction. It might be preferred in contexts where clarity of ritual direction is prioritized over literal rendering.

[D]Or: "Following this, he should again make confession and pronounce:" — This translation emphasizes the repetitive nature of the confession ritual, which might be helpful in contexts where the cyclical or iterative aspects of the deathbed ritual are being highlighted.

[2]The Hebrew "harbeh imo pedut" literally means "with Him is abundant redemption." The term "pedut" (redemption) carries connotations of ransom or release from bondage, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context connects to the soul's release from both sin and physical existence at death.

[1]This confession reflects a rabbinic interpretation that Israel's sins collectively involve denial of three elements: God's sovereignty, the Davidic monarchy (with its messianic implications), and the sanctity of the Temple. This threefold pattern structures the entire prayer.

[iii]This concluding verse offers reassurance of complete redemption from sin, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper deathbed confession (vidui) as facilitating atonement and spiritual purification before death.

[iv]Cf. Confession (vidui) prayers in Ma'avar Yabok — Psalm 130 serves as a theological foundation for the confession rituals in Ma'avar Yabok, expressing the same movement from depths of sin to heights of divine mercy that characterizes the book's approach to death as spiritual transition. | Cf. Psalm 130 in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences — The inclusion of this psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences for the sick and dying reflects its thematic appropriateness for contexts of distress and its expression of hope in divine forgiveness even in the face of mortality. | Cf. References to "awaiting salvation" in Ma'avar Yabok — The psalm's emphasis on waiting and hoping ("I wait for the LORD, my soul waits") resonates with Ma'avar Yabok's recurring theme of patient anticipation of divine salvation, both in terms of physical healing and ultimate spiritual redemption.

[i]This phrase marks an important transition in the deathbed ritual sequence. Having completed certain prayers, the dying person (or someone reciting on their behalf) is instructed to return to the formal confession (vidui). This demonstrates the central importance of confession in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to proper spiritual preparation for death.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 22 — This instruction is likely drawing on the extensive discussion of vidui (confession) found in Discourse 2, Chapter 22, where the author explains both the practical procedures and mystical dimensions of deathbed confession. The instruction to 'return and confess' reflects the text's emphasis on confession as a central element of proper preparation for death. | Cf. Zohar III:88a — Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession before death is likely informed by Zoharic passages like III:88a, which explains how confession purifies the soul and facilitates its proper transition to the next world. The instruction to 'return and confess' reflects this Zoharic understanding of confession as essential spiritual preparation.

שַׁבְנוּ וְנִחַמְנוּ וְנִתְחָרַטְנוּ וּשְׁלַשְׁתָּם
בִּקַּשְׁנוּ. אֶת יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ. וְאֶת דָּוִד
4925 מַלְכֵּנוּ. וּבֵית קָדְשֵׁנוּ וְתִפְאַרְתֵּנוּ.
בַּכָּתוּב אַחַר יָשׁוּבוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
וּבִקְשׁוּ אֶת יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיהֶם וְאֶת דָּוִד
מַלְכָּם וּפָחֲדוּ אֶל יְיָ וְאֶל טוּבוֹ
בְּאַחֲרִית הַיָּמִים. אָנָּא יְיָ הִמָּצֵא
4930 וְהִתְחַנַּשׂ לָנוּ וַעֲשֵׂה עִמָּנוּ אוֹת
לְטוֹבָה וְהָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ עַל מִקְדָּשְׁךָ
הַשָּׁמֵם לְמַעַן אֲדֹנָי וְקַבֵּץ נְפוּצוֹת
קַוֶּיךָ וְיִבָּנֶה בֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ הֶלֵא
יָדַעְנוּ כִּי בוֹחַר אַתָּה בְּבֶן יִשַׁי
4935 וּבְכֵן יִתְגַּדֵּל שִׁמְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ עַל
יִשְׂרָאֵל עַמֶּךָ וּבְכֵן תֵּן פַּחְדְּךָ יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵינוּ עַל כָּל מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וְאֵימָתְךָ
עַל כָּל מַה שֶּׁבָּרָאתָ: עַל כֵּן נְקַוֶּה
לְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ לִרְאוֹת מְהֵרָה
4940 בְּתִפְאֶרֶת עֻזֶּךָ, לְהַעֲבִיר גִּלּוּלִים
מִן הָאָרֶץ וְהָאֱלִילִים כָּרוֹת
יִכָּרֵתוּן, לְתַקֵּן עוֹלָם בְּמַלְכוּת
שַׁדַּי, וְכָל בְּנֵי בָשָׂר יִקְרְאוּ בִשְׁמֶךָ
לְהַפְנוֹת אֵלֶיךָ כָּל רִשְׁעֵי אָרֶץ.
4945 יַכִּירוּ וְיֵדְעוּ כָּל יֹשְׁבֵי תֵּבֵל כִּי לְךָ
תִכְרַע כָּל בֶּרֶךְ. תִּשָּׁבַע כָּל לָשׁוֹן,
לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ יִכְרְעוּ וְיִפֹּלוּ.
וְלִכְבוֹד שִׁמְךָ יְקָר יִתֵּנוּ. וִיקַבְּלוּ
כֻלָּם אֶת עוֹל מַלְכוּתֶךָ. וְתִמְלוֹךְ
4950 עֲלֵיהֶם מְהֵרָה לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד. כִּי
הַמַּלְכוּת שֶׁלְּךָ הִיא וּלְעוֹלְמֵי עַד
תִּמְלוֹךְ בְּכָבוֹד: [i]

we have regretted, we have repented, and we have sought all three:[1] the LORD our God, David our king, and our holy and glorious Temple. As it is written: "Afterward, the children of Israel shall return and seek the LORD their God and David their king, and they shall fear the LORD and His goodness in the latter days." Please, O LORD, be found by us and be sought by us, and perform for us a sign for good. Shine Your face upon Your desolate sanctuary for the sake of the Lord, and gather the dispersed of those who hope in You,[2] and may the Temple be rebuilt. Indeed, we know that You have chosen the son of Jesse, and thus may Your name, O LORD our God, be magnified over Israel Your people. And thus, instill Your fear, O LORD our God, upon all Your works, and Your dread upon all You have created. 5215R 5220R 5225R

Therefore, we hope to You, O LORD our God, to see speedily the glory of Your might, to remove idols from the earth, and false gods shall be utterly cut off, to perfect the world under the kingdom of the Almighty, and all flesh shall call upon Your name, to turn to You all the wicked of the earth. All the inhabitants of the world shall recognize and know that to You every knee shall bow, every tongue shall swear. Before You, O LORD our God, they shall kneel and fall, and to the glory of Your name they shall give honor. They shall all accept the yoke of Your kingdom,[3] and You shall reign over them speedily forever and ever. For the kingdom is Yours, and to all eternity You shall reign in glory. 5230R 5235R 5240R

[2]The original Hebrew uses the expression 'u-shlashtem bikashnu' (literally 'and the three of them we sought'), which creates a deliberate contrast with the threefold denial mentioned earlier. I've made this explicit by adding 'all three' to clarify the connection.

[3]The phrase 'nefutzot kovecha' (literally 'the scattered of those who hope for You') is a poetic reference to the Jewish diaspora, connecting the idea of physical dispersion with the continued hope for divine redemption.

[1]The image of accepting 'the yoke of the kingdom' (ol malchut) is a central rabbinic concept referring to willingly submitting to divine sovereignty, particularly through fulfilling commandments. This phrase appears in the daily Shema prayer and is echoed here in an eschatological context.

[i]Cf. Aleinu Prayer — By incorporating elements of the Aleinu, this prayer connects the specific confession of denying David's kingship with the broader Jewish eschatological vision of universal divine recognition and the perfection of the world. | Cf. Hosea 3:5 — This biblical verse serves as the textual foundation for the prayer's central theme: the eventual restoration of Israel's relationship with both God and the Davidic (messianic) kingship. | Cf. 1 Kings 12:16 — This historical rejection of Davidic rule is reinterpreted in the prayer as a spiritual failing requiring repentance, connecting political history with theological meaning. | Cf. Yom Kippur Confessional Prayers — By using the language of ritual confession, the prayer frames the historical rejection of Davidic kingship as a sin requiring atonement, elevating a political event to the level of religious transgression.

[ii]This opening formula 'U'vchen' (And therefore) marks the beginning of a section from the High Holiday Amidah prayer that focuses on God's sovereignty and the hope for divine kingship.

וּבְכֵן תֵּן כָּבוֹד יְיָ לְעַמֶּךָ[ii] תְּהִלָּה
לִירֵאֶיךָ וְתִקְוָה טוֹבָה לְדוֹרְשֶׁיךָ
4955 וּפִתְחוֹן פֶּה לַמְיַחֲלִים לָךְ שִׂמְחָה
לְאַרְצֶךָ וְשָׂשׂוֹן לְעִירֶךָ וּצְמִיחַת
קֶרֶן לְדָוִד עַבְדֶּךָ[i] וַעֲרִיכַת נֵר לְבֶן
יִשַׁי מְשִׁיחֶךָ בִּמְהֵרָה בְיָמֵינוּ: וּבְכֵן
צַדִּיקִים יִרְאוּ וְיִשְׂמָחוּ וְישָׁרִים
4960 יַעֲלוּזוּ וַחֲסִידִים בְּרִנָּה יָגִילוּ
וְעוֹלָתָה תִּקְפָּץ פִּיהָ וְכָל הָרִשְׁעָה
כֻּלָּהּ בֶּעָשָׁן תִּכְלֶה[ii] כִּי תַעֲבִיר
מֶמְשֶׁלֶת זָדוֹן מִן הָאָרֶץ: וְתִמְלוֹךְ
אַתָּה יְיָ לְבַדֶּךָ מְהֵרָה עַל כָּל
4965 מַעֲשֶׂיךָ בִּירוּשָׁלַיִם עִירֶךָ וּבְהַר
צִיּוֹן מִשְׁכַּן כְּבוֹדֶךָ כַּכָּתוּב כֹּה
אָמַר יְיָ שַׁבְתִּי אֶל צִיּוֹן וְשָׁכַנְתִּי
בְּתוֹךְ יְרוּשָׁלַיִם וְנִקְרְאָה יְרוּשָׁלַיִם
עִיר הָאֱמֶת וְהַר יְיָ צְבָאוֹת הַר
4970 הַקֹּדֶשׁ וְעָלוּ מוֹשִׁיעִים בְּהַר צִיּוֹן
וְהָיָה יְיָ לְמֶלֶךְ עַל כָּל הָאָרֶץ
בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא יִהְיֶה יְיָ אֶחָד וּשְׁמוֹ
אֶחָד:[iii] וְעוֹד כָּתוּב וְעַבְדִּי
דָוִד מֶלֶךְ עֲלֵיהֶם וְרוֹעֶה אֶחָד
4975 יִהְיֶה לְכֻלָּם וּבְמִשְׁפָּטַי יֵלֵכוּ
וְחֻקּוֹתַי יִשְׁמְרוּ וְעָשׂוּ אוֹתָם וְעוֹד
כָּתוּב וְכָרַתִּי לָהֶם בְּרִית שָׁלוֹם
בְּרִית עוֹלָם יִהְיֶה אוֹתָם וּנְתַתִּים
וְהִרְבֵּיתִי אוֹתָם וְנָתַתִּי אֶת מִקְדָּשִׁי

And therefore, grant honor, O LORD, to Your people,[1] praise to those who fear You, good hope to those who seek You, and eloquent speech to those who wait for You;[A] joy to Your land and gladness to Your city, and the flourishing of the horn of David Your servant,[2] and the preparation of a lamp for the son of Jesse, Your anointed one, speedily in our days. 5245R
And therefore, the righteous shall see and rejoice, the upright shall exult, and the pious shall sing with joy, while injustice shall shut its mouth[B] and all wickedness shall vanish like smoke, for You will remove the dominion of arrogance from the earth.[3] Then You alone, O LORD, shall reign speedily over all Your works in Jerusalem Your city and on Mount Zion, the dwelling place of Your glory, as it is written: "Thus says the LORD: I have returned to Zion and I will dwell in the midst of Jerusalem, and Jerusalem shall be called the City of Truth, and the mountain of the LORD of hosts, the Holy Mountain." And "Saviors shall ascend Mount Zion, and the LORD shall be King over all the earth; on that day the LORD shall be One and His name One." And it is further written: "And My servant David shall be king over them, and there shall be one shepherd for all of them, and they shall follow My ordinances and observe My statutes and perform them." And it is further written: "And I will make with them a 5250R 5255R 5260R 5265R

[A] Or: "and an opening of the mouth to those who hope in You" — This more literal translation preserves the Hebrew idiom 'pitchon peh' (opening of the mouth), which conveys both the ability to speak and the opportunity to express oneself. The context suggests both the granting of opportunity to speak and the capacity for eloquence.

[B] Or: "and iniquity shall shut its mouth" — The term 'olatah' can refer to both injustice and iniquity or wickedness. This alternate translation emphasizes the moral dimension of the term rather than its legal implications.

[2] This prayer begins with the liturgical formula 'U'vchen' (And therefore) that links divine sovereignty with human flourishing, suggesting that God's kingship is manifest through Israel's honor.

[3] The Hebrew term 'keren' (horn) symbolizes power and sovereignty, while 'ner' (lamp) represents both guidance and the perpetual light of monarchy. These dual metaphors express hope for messianic restoration.

[4] The Hebrew term 'memshelet zadon' (dominion of arrogance) can be understood as referring to both earthly tyrannies and spiritual forces of evil. In Ma'avar Yabok's context of death rituals, this may also represent the defeat of death itself.

[iii] The 'horn' (keren) is a biblical symbol of strength and power, while the 'lamp' (ner) represents continuity and guidance. Together these metaphors express hope for the restoration of the Davidic monarchy.

[iv] The image of wickedness vanishing like smoke recalls both the sacrificial smoke of the Temple and the impermanence of evil in contrast to God's eternal justice.

[i] This verse from Zechariah 14:9 is a central part of the Aleinu prayer and expresses the ultimate hope for universal recognition of divine unity.

בְּתוֹכָם לְעוֹלָם: אָנָּא יְיָ כָּתְבֵנוּ
לִגְאֻלָּה אָנָּא יְיָ כָּתְבֵנוּ לִישׁוּעָה
וְתָקֵל חֲבָלֵי מָשִׁיחַ מֵעָלֵינוּ וַעֲנֵנוּ
בְּיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ וְאִם רַבּוּ עֲוֹנֵנוּ חַתֵּר
חַתֵּר יוֹצֵר בְּרֵאשִׁית. סְלַח סְלַח
אָבִיר יַעֲקֹב. מְחוֹל מְחוֹל קָדוֹשׁ
יִשְׂרָאֵל. כִּי אַדִּיר מְלָכִים אַתָּה.
מֶלֶךְ אַדִּיר. מֶלֶךְ בָּרוּךְ. מֶלֶךְ
גָּדוֹל.[i] מֶלֶךְ דָּגוּל. מֶלֶךְ הָדוּר.
מֶלֶךְ וָתִיק. מֶלֶךְ זָךְ. מֶלֶךְ חָנוּן.
מֶלֶךְ טָהוֹר. מֶלֶךְ יָשָׁר. מֶלֶךְ
כָּבוֹד. מֶלֶךְ לָעַד. מֶלֶךְ מְרוֹמָם.
מֶלֶךְ נוֹרָא. מֶלֶךְ סוֹלֵחַ. מֶלֶךְ
עוֹזֵר. מֶלֶךְ פּוֹדֶה. מֶלֶךְ צַדִּיק.
מֶלֶךְ קָרוֹב. מֶלֶךְ רַחוּם. מֶלֶךְ
שׁוֹמֵר. מֶלֶךְ תָּם. לָמָּה לָךְ אֵיבָה
עִם זֶרַע אַבְרָהָם אֹהֲבֶךָ.[ii] לָמָּה
לָךְ קִנְאָה עִם זֶרַע יִצְחָק עַבְדֶּךָ.
לָמָּה לָךְ תַּחֲרוּת עִם זֶרַע יַעֲקֹב
תְּמִימֶךָ. כִּי קִנְיַן שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ
קָרָאתָ אוֹתָם. אָנָּא רַחֵם עַל
פְּלֵטַת גּוֹלַת אֲרִיאֵל[iii] הֲבָנִים אֵין
לְיִשְׂרָאֵל. הַעַל אֵלֶּה תִּתְאַפַּק יְיָ
תֶּחֱשֶׁה וּתְעַנֵּנוּ עַד מְאֹד: אַל תִּנָּצֵן
לְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ אַל תְּנַבֵּל כִּסֵּא כְבוֹדֶךָ
זְכוֹר אַל תָּפֵר בְּרִיתְךָ אִתָּנוּ: כִּי

covenant of peace, an everlasting covenant it shall be with them,[A] and I will establish them and multiply them, and I will place My sanctuary among them forever." Please, O LORD, inscribe us for redemption; please, O LORD, inscribe us for salvation,[1] and lighten the birth pangs of the Messiah from upon us,[2] and answer us on the day we call. And if our iniquities have multiplied, release, release, O Creator of the Beginning; forgive, forgive, O Mighty One of Jacob; pardon, pardon, O Holy One of Israel. For You are the Mightiest of kings. King Mighty, King Blessed, King Great,[3] King Distinguished, King Glorious, King Venerable, King Pure, King Gracious, King Clean, King Upright, King Honorable, King Eternal, King Exalted, King Awesome, King Forgiving, King Helper, King Redeemer, King Righteous, King Near, King Merciful, King Guardian, King Perfect. Why do You harbor enmity against the seed of Abraham, Your beloved? Why do You have jealousy against the seed of Isaac, the one bound for You? Why do You maintain rivalry with the seed of Jacob, Your innocent one? For You called them the possession of heaven and earth. Please have mercy upon the remnant of the exiled Ariel;[B] does Israel have no sons?[C] Will You restrain Yourself over these things, O LORD? Will You remain silent and afflict us to the

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[A] Or: "it shall be an everlasting covenant for them" — This translation more clearly communicates the meaning while maintaining the emphasis on the perpetual nature of the covenant.

[A] Or: "Please have mercy upon the surviving remnant of Jerusalem's exile" — 'Ariel' is a poetic name for Jerusalem, and this translation makes the reference more explicit for readers unfamiliar with this biblical epithet for the holy city.

[B] Or: "are there no children for Israel?" — This translation captures the plaintive quality of the rhetorical question while allowing for a broader interpretation of 'banim' as children rather than specifically sons.

[1] The language of divine inscription echoes the High Holiday prayers where God inscribes individuals in the Book of Life. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this links the individual's death with the larger themes of judgment and redemption.

[2] The 'birth pangs of the Messiah' (chevlei mashiach) refers to the suffering and tribulations believed to precede the messianic era. In the context of death rituals, this acknowledges personal suffering while placing it within a redemptive framework.

[3] This alphabetical listing of divine attributes follows the complete Hebrew alphabet (alef through tav), symbolizing the totality of divine qualities. Each attribute begins with a successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet.

[ii] This passage lists divine attributes in an alphabetical acrostic, beginning with the Hebrew letters alef, bet, gimel, and continuing through the entire alphabet. Such acrostics are common in liturgical poetry and symbolize completeness and divine perfection.

[i] This rhetorical questioning of God's apparent hostility toward Israel follows a traditional Jewish literary pattern of respectful challenge to divine justice, similar to Abraham's negotiation for Sodom and Moses' intercession for Israel.

[ii] 'Ariel' is a poetic name for Jerusalem found in Isaiah 29:1, where the prophet addresses the city as 'Ariel, the city where David encamped.'

אַתָּה אָבִינוּ כִּי אַבְרָהָם לֹא יְדָעָנוּ וְיִשְׂרָאֵל לֹא יַכִּירֵנוּ[i] אַתָּה יְיָ אָבִינוּ גּוֹאֲלֵנוּ מֵעוֹלָם שְׁמֶךָ: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ לְעוֹלָם אָמֵן וְאָמֵן: [ii]

extreme? Do not spurn for the sake of Your name, do not disgrace the throne of Your glory, remember, do not annul Your covenant with us. For You are our Father, though Abraham does not know us and Israel does not recognize us; You, O LORD, are our Father, our Redeemer from everlasting is Your name.[1] Blessed be the LORD forever, amen and amen. 5300R

פרק ח׳

Chapter 8

אין לעשות לחולה רפואה בשכר אלא בנגד הטורח וההוצאות ואם יאמרו אנשי ביתו לרופא נקנה ונטרח ונעסוק רק תאמר לנו מה לעשו׳ אין לרופא ליקח מהם שום דבר משום והלכת בדרכיו.[iii] ועוד כי הרפואה היא ממקום הרחמים פשוטים אשר לא יקוה לאיש ולא ייחל לבני אדם וזהו כי אל רופא רחמן

One should not provide medical treatment to a sick person for payment, but only in exchange for the effort and expenses.[A] If the patient's family members say to the physician, "We will purchase, make the effort, and take care of everything—just tell us what to do," the physician should not take anything from them, in accordance with the principle "You shall walk in His ways." Furthermore, healing comes from a place of pure compassion that does not depend on any person nor wait for human beings, which 5R 10R

[A] Or: "A physician should not charge a patient for medical treatment itself, but only for their effort and expenses" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the halakhic principle being described, making it explicit that this refers to physicians' fees rather than a general statement about providing treatment.

[1] The text concludes by affirming God's eternal role as Redeemer (go'alenu), linking the personal journey of the soul after death with the cosmic redemption of all Israel, suggesting that death itself is merely another exile from which God will ultimately redeem the soul.

[i] "You shall walk in His ways" (Deuteronomy 28:9)—a biblical commandment to emulate God's attributes, here applied to healing without seeking profit, as God heals without compensation.

[ii] Cf. High Holiday liturgy (Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur prayers) — This passage incorporates significant portions of the High Holiday liturgy, particularly from the Amidah prayer, which focuses on God's sovereignty and the hope for messianic redemption. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these prayers for divine kingship and restoration connect the individual's death journey to the larger cosmic redemption. | Cf. Zechariah 8:3 — This biblical quotation from Zechariah affirms God's promise to restore Jerusalem, which serves in Ma'avar Yabok as a parallel to the soul's own journey toward redemption and divine dwelling. | Cf. Obadiah 1:21 and Zechariah 14:9 — This passage combines verses from Obadiah and Zechariah that prophecy ultimate divine sovereignty. In the context of death rituals, this affirms that the individual's soul journey is part of a larger cosmic process culminating in divine unity. | Cf. Ezekiel 37:24-26 — These verses from Ezekiel's vision of resurrection and restoration connect directly to Ma'avar Yabok's themes of death and renewal. The mention of the 'covenant of peace' is particularly significant in a text dealing with the soul's peaceful transition after death. | Cf. Isaiah 63:16 — This reference from Isaiah emphasizes the direct relationship between the individual and God, beyond ancestral mediation. In the context of death rituals, it provides comfort that even when separated from the community of Israel through death, God remains the ultimate Father and Redeemer of the soul. | Cf. Alphabetical acrostic of divine attributes — This alphabetical listing of divine attributes represents the completeness of God's kingship. In Ma'avar Yabok's context of death rituals, it suggests that the soul's journey is encompassed within the totality of divine qualities, providing complete protection and guidance.

[iii] This verse from Isaiah 63:16 emphasizes God's direct parental relationship with Israel, suggesting that even when the patriarchs might not recognize their descendants, God's connection remains unbroken.

ונאמן אתה: וכשאדם חולה ימהר לסדר ענייניו ולצוות לביתו. והנה מצינו כי נאמר לחזקיהו צו לביתך.[i] וצוואתו תהיה בפני עדים ואפילו לאביו לא יאמין כל שכן לבניו ולאשתו. ויזרז אז לבניו כי ישמרו דרך ה׳ לעשות צדקה ומשפט. וכשהאב מצוה לבניו מה שחפץ שיעשה תחלה יאמר לו באחרונה. ואם יודע שבניו בני מריבה יחלקם קודם מותו לבל יגבירו כחות הקטגוריא בהתעצמם בריבם זה על זה ונמצא שם שמים מתחלל ביניהם בשבועות וחרופים ולהביא דינם לפני שופט ובמניעת בניו מדברי ריבות יכוין להחליש כחות הדין ולהוצי׳ השטן מביתו כי במקו׳ מרובה שם ינוח כדאמר ווי דאפקיה רבי מאיר מההוא ביתא.[ii] ואוי לנפש האב הגורם ברוע הנהגתו קטטה בין בניו שגם הוא לא ינוח על משכבו בהשקט ונותן כח לדיני׳ להתגבר עליו ח״ו כי מגלגלין וכו׳ ואם הוא חכם ורואה את הנולד ומתקן עד מקום שידו מגעת עליו נאמר וחוסה במותו צדיק. ואם הבנים מחמת צוואתו יתנהגו באחוה

is why we say, "For You are a merciful and faithful healing God."

When a person falls ill, they should quickly put their affairs in order and issue instructions to their household. Indeed, we find that Hezekiah was told, "Set your house in order." One's final testament should be made before witnesses, and one should not trust even one's father, much less one's children or wife. At that time, one should urge one's children to keep the way of the Lord, to perform acts of charity and justice. When a father instructs his children about what he wants done first, he should mention it last. If he knows his children are quarrelsome, he should divide his estate before his death to prevent strengthening the forces of accusation[A] through their intensified quarreling with one another, which would cause God's name to be profaned among them through oaths and insults, and by bringing their case before a judge. By preventing his children from engaging in disputes, he intends to weaken the forces of judgment and remove Satan from his house,[B] for in a house of strife, there Satan rests, as it is said, "Woe that Rabbi Meir expelled him from that house."

Woe to the soul of a father who, through his poor management, causes quarreling among his children,[C] for he too will not rest peacefully in his grave, and he gives power to the forces of judgment to prevail against him, God forbid,[1] for "they roll..."[2] But if he is wise and foresees what will be born of his actions, making corrections to the extent

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[B] Or: "the prosecuting spiritual forces" — The term has kabbalistic connotations referring to actual spiritual entities that act as accusers or prosecutors in the celestial court, rather than just abstract 'forces of accusation'.

[C] Or: "to weaken the powers of divine judgment and drive Satan away from his household" — This alternate translation better captures the kabbalistic concept of 'forces of judgment' (כחות הדין) as specifically divine judgment forces in the spiritual realms, not just general judgment.

[A] Or: "Woe to the soul of a father whose misguided leadership causes strife among his children" — The term הנהגתו refers more to leadership or governance than merely management, suggesting the father's role as a leader of the household rather than just an administrator.

[1] The Hebrew abbreviation 'ח״ו' (חס ושלום) literally means 'mercy and peace' and functions as an apotropaic formula to ward off the negative thing being mentioned.

[2] This is an abbreviated reference to the Talmudic principle 'מגלגלין זכות על ידי זכאי וחובה על ידי חייב' (merit is brought about through the meritorious and guilt through the guilty), suggesting that divine judgment operates through cause and effect.

[ii] This quotes God's instruction to King Hezekiah in Isaiah 38:1 when he was deathly ill, providing biblical precedent for putting one's affairs in order when facing serious illness.

[iii] This refers to a Talmudic story about Rabbi Meir driving Satan out of a house, with the implication that Satan then found another dwelling place. The author uses this to illustrate that discord creates a spiritual environment where negative forces can take residence.

ובשלום ובמישור יתנו מעדנים לנפשו וישכב ואין מחריד ואם רוע מזג בניו גרם זה אין לו אח״כ בזה אשם כי אב לא ישא בעון הבן. ועל זה נאמר יכבדו בניו ולא ידע. ברם מבעי ליה להביט מראשית אחרית לבל יהיה הוא והממון שהוריש להם סבה רחוקה או קרובה להבעיר אשו של גיהנם עליו ועליהם ומגביה ח״ו בחות היכל חמישי מהיכלי התמורות הנקרא איבה.[i] ועיקר כונתו תהיה לשמים ולתקון עליון ולהשבית אויב ומתנקם[3] למעלה ולמטה ממנו ומבניו.[ii]

he is able, of him it is said, "The righteous finds rest in his death." If, because of his instructions, his children behave with brotherhood, peace, and uprightness, they will provide delights for his soul, and he will lie down with none to make him afraid. However, if the poor disposition of his children caused this strife, he bears no guilt afterward, for "a father shall not bear the iniquity of his son." Concerning this it is said, "His sons come to honor, but he does not know it."

Nevertheless, he must look from the beginning to the end, lest he and the property he bequeaths to them become a distant or immediate cause for kindling the fire of Gehenna upon him and upon them, and—God forbid—elevate the powers of the fifth palace among the palaces of exchanges, which is called "enmity." His primary intention should be directed toward Heaven and the supernal rectification, to quiet the enemy and avenger[1] above and below, away from himself and his children.

ואם מצוה לקיים דברי המת יהיה מי שיהיה כ״ש שחובה על הבנים שלא לחטות ימין ושמאל מצוואת אביהם הנעשית ביושר

If there is a commandment to fulfill the words of the deceased, whoever they may be,[A] how much more so is it an obligation for children[2] not to deviate right or left from their father's will when it is made with

[A] Or: "If it is a commandment to fulfill the wishes of the deceased, regardless of who they were" — This alternative translation may better convey the sense that the obligation applies universally, regardless of the deceased person's status.

[3] This phrase alludes to Psalm 8:3, 'להשבית אויב ומתנקם', which speaks of silencing God's enemies. Here it refers to neutralizing negative spiritual forces both in celestial realms ('above') and earthly domains ('below').

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'כ״ש' (kal va-chomer) indicates an a fortiori argument: if a general obligation exists to fulfill any deceased person's wishes, then children have an even stronger obligation toward their parents.

[i] This refers to Kabbalistic teachings about the structure of the impure spiritual realms, where the fifth palace among the 'palaces of exchange' (impure counterparts to the holy palaces) is associated with hatred and enmity. Family discord is understood to empower these negative spiritual realms.

[ii] Cf. You shall walk in His ways (והלכת בדרכיו) — This biblical phrase is invoked as the basis for the ethical obligation of physicians to act compassionately like God, providing healing without seeking profit beyond necessary expenses. | Cf. Set your house in order (צו לביתך) — This phrase comes from God's instruction to King Hezekiah when he was ill and expected to die, serving as biblical precedent for making final arrangements when seriously ill. | Cf. Woe that Rabbi Meir expelled him from that house (ווי דאפקיה רבי מאיר מההוא ביתא) — This appears to reference a Talmudic story where Rabbi Meir expelled Satan/discord from a house, with the implication that Satan then found another dwelling place, teaching that strife creates a dwelling place for negative spiritual forces. | Cf. The righteous finds rest in his death (וחוסה במותו צדיק) — This adapts the biblical verse that states 'the righteous has hope in his death' to emphasize that a righteous person who wisely arranges his affairs will find spiritual rest after death. | Cf. Fifth palace among the palaces of exchanges (היכל חמישי מהיכלי התמורות) — This refers to the kabbalistic concept of impure spiritual palaces (היכלי התמורות) that mirror the holy palaces, with the fifth one specifically associated with hatred and strife, suggesting that family discord empowers negative spiritual forces.

ולש״ש. ואם האב צוה לבנו דבר מה וחכמי המקום עם הבן נראה להם שהוא נגד כבודו אין צריך לקיים דבריו. אבל בזיון שהוא לכפרת נפשו כבוד יחשב לו: וכן המתפלל על אביו או על רבו לפום ריהטא נראה כי אין לומר בתחנתו רפא נא לאדוני אבי או אבא מרי או רבי ואלופי כי שלמה אמר בדברו עם ה׳ דוד אבי וכן אלישע אמר אלהי אליהו ולא אמר אדוני שאין גבהות לפני המקום. ואוריה נתחייב הריגה למלכות על שאמר לפני דוד ואדוני יואב ברם נראה לפי הדין שבאותם שאסור להזכיר שמם מותר לומר אבי או רבי אך לא יוסיף על זה. וראוי לדעת שכשחולאים יוצאים לעולם הם ע״י מלאכים משולחים הנקראת משלחת מלאכי רעים היוצאים מפתח שני ומפתח רביעי שבהיכל השלישי מהיכלי התמורות הנקראים אופל: ובפרשת תרומה דף רמ״ד אמר שמוצאם מזרוע שמאל מקומות הקליפה שהוא בשית דרגין כנתבאר שם: [i]

integrity and for the sake of Heaven. However, if a father commanded his son to do something, and the local sages along with the son believe it to be against his honor, he need not fulfill his words. But humiliation that serves as atonement for his soul should be considered an honor to him.

Similarly, regarding one who prays for his father or teacher, at first glance it appears inappropriate to say in one's supplication "please heal my lord father" or "my father, my teacher" or "my teacher and my guide," since Solomon, when speaking with God, said "David my father," and likewise Elisha said "God of Elijah" and did not say "my lord," for there is no arrogance before the Omnipresent.[1] Uriah was condemned to death by the kingdom because he said before David "and my lord Joab." However, it appears that according to the law, for those whose names are forbidden to mention, it is permitted to say "my father" or "my teacher," but one should not add more than this.

It is important to know that when diseases come into the world, they come through dispatched angels called "the company of evil angels"[A][2] that emerge from the second entrance and the fourth entrance of the third palace of the Palaces of Exchange, which are called "darknes[B]s."[3] And in Parashat Terumah, page 244, it states that their origin is from the left arm, the places of the husk (kelipah) which exist in

[B]Or: "that emerge from the second and fourth gates of the third hall in the Heichalot HaTemurot (Palaces of Exchange), which are called "Ofel" (darkness)" — This alternative retains the Hebrew term 'Ofel' for darkness and 'Heichalot HaTemurot' for Palaces of Exchange, which may be preferable when dealing with technical kabbalistic terminology. It also uses 'gates' instead of 'entrances' which may better reflect the mystical concept.

[A]Or: "that emerge from the second and fourth gates of the third hall in the Heichalot HaTemurot (Palaces of Exchange), which are called "Ofel" (darkness)" — This alternative retains the Hebrew term 'Ofel' for darkness and 'Heichalot HaTemurot' for Palaces of Exchange, which may be preferable when dealing with technical kabbalistic terminology. It also uses 'gates' instead of 'entrances' which may better reflect the mystical concept.

[2]The Hebrew term 'המקום' (HaMakom, literally 'The Place') is a traditional epithet for God, which I've translated as 'the Omnipresent' to convey its theological significance while maintaining the literal connection to place/location.

[3]The term 'משלחת מלאכי רעים' appears in Psalm 78:49 describing the plagues in Egypt. In kabbalistic literature, this concept was expanded to explain the spiritual origins of disease.

[1]The Hebrew terms 'היכלי התמורות' (Palaces of Exchange) and 'אופל' (darkness) are technical kabbalistic terms referring to spiritual realms associated with impurity and negative forces. These concepts are elaborated in zoharic literature as part of a complex mystical cosmology.

[i]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The text cites this specific passage in the Zohar to explain the kabbalistic source of illness as emanating from specific locations within the mystical 'Palaces of Exchange' (Heichalot HaTemurot). This reference grounds the author's mystical explanation of disease in authoritative kabbalistic literature. | Cf. Talmud, Gittin 14b-15a — While not explicitly

six levels, as explained there.[A]

עוד כתוב בספר החסידים כי
חסיד אחד היה רוחץ באמבטי
וראה זוהר על ראשו ועל
המים[i] ואמר לאשתו ששאלה
אותו מהו זוהר זה כי הוא מהדיו
שנשאר בקולמוס אחר הכתיבה
העליונה שהקב״ה מקנחו בראש
הצדיקים שהגיע זמנן ליפטר[ii] כי
הקב״ה עושה סימן לצדיקים
העתידים ליפטר קודם פטירתן
ואולי בזה יתוסף להם רוח טהרה
על דרך תוסף רוחם יגועון. ודיו
יהיה מאור התורה הכתובה
למעלה בדיו שחור המאיר באש
שחורה על גבי אש לבנה.[iii] ואמר
שם כי באותו שבוע מת אותו
צדיק וכדומה לזה כתב מורי
הגאון מפאנו זצ״ל על קירון

It is further written in Sefer Hasidim that a certain pious man was bathing in a tub when he saw a radiance upon his head and upon the water. When his wife asked him what this radiance was, he told her that it was from the ink that remained on the quill after the supernal writing,[B] which the Holy One, blessed be He, wipes on the heads of the righteous whose time has come to depart from this world.[1] For the Holy One, blessed be He, makes a sign for the righteous who are destined to depart before their passing, and perhaps through this, a spirit of purity is added to them,[2] in accordance with "You add to their spirit, they expire" (Psalm 104:29). And this ink would be from the light of the Torah written above in black ink that shines as black fire upon white fire. And it says there that in that same week, that righteous man died. Similarly, my teacher, the Gaon of Fano, of blessed memory, wrote concerning

[B] Or: "And in the Zohar section on Parashat Terumah, page 244, it states that these emanate from the left arm, from the realms of the kelipah (impure husks) which exist in six gradations, as explained there" — This alternative makes it clearer that the reference is specifically to the Zohar commentary on Parashat Terumah, and provides more precise kabbalistic terminology for the concepts of 'kelipah' and 'levels/gradations'.

[C] Or: "the residual ink on the divine quill after the celestial writing" — This translation better captures the mystical imagery of divine instruments used in heavenly writing, emphasizing the celestial origin of this substance.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'שהגיע זמנן ליפטר' uses the euphemistic term 'to depart' (ליפטר) rather than explicitly mentioning death, a common practice in Jewish texts.

[1] The text creates a wordplay connecting the verse 'תוסף רוחם יגועון' (literally 'You add to their spirit, they expire') with the idea that righteous people receive additional spiritual purity before death. This creatively reinterprets what is typically understood as God taking away breath (causing death) into God adding spiritual quality.

cited, the passage's opening discussion about the obligation to fulfill the wishes of the deceased (mitzvah lekayem divrei ha-met) appears to draw on talmudic discussions about this principle. The Talmud in Gittin discusses the extent and limitations of this obligation, which informs the author's halakhic framework. | Cf. 1 Kings 1:13 — The text cites this biblical precedent to establish rules about how one should refer to one's father or teacher in prayer, using it to demonstrate that certain honorific titles can be appropriately omitted when addressing God. | Cf. 2 Kings 2:14 — This biblical reference is used alongside the Solomon example to establish proper protocol for referring to one's teacher in prayer, showing that Elisha did not use the honorific 'my lord' when referring to his teacher Elijah in a prayer context.

[ii] This description of a luminous radiance appearing on a righteous person shortly before death reflects the Jewish mystical belief that the souls of the righteous begin to emit divine light as they prepare to depart from the physical world.

[iii] This striking metaphor presents the Holy One as using the heads of righteous individuals as places to wipe His divine quill, suggesting an intimate relationship between God and the righteous as they approach death.

[i] The imagery of 'black fire upon white fire' refers to a famous rabbinic description of the Torah as it exists in heaven (Talmud, Yerushalmi Shekalim 6:1). This mystical concept depicts the divine text as being composed of black fire (the letters) written upon white fire (the parchment).

עור פניו של משה רבינו עליו
השלום מהיכן בא לו: וממעשה
הכתוב בזהר פרשת ויקהל דף
קצ״ז מוכח שצריך להסתיר אדם
עצמו בעת שמ״ה[i] בעיר ח״ו ויש
לו רשות להשחית וכבר אמרו
דבר בעיר כנס רגליך ופי׳
כן דרך אשה מנאפת דא הוא
מ״ה[ii] והכי אקרי אכלה ומחתה
פיה אוקידת עלמא בשלהוביהי
וקטלת בני נשא עד לא מטי
זמנייהו ואמרה לא פעלתי
און דהא דינא בעאת עלייהו
דאשתכחו בחובין ובדינא קשוט
מיתו. ונ״ל מדברי הזהר כי מ״ה
מוצאו מהיכל שני של התמורות
הנקרא שחת טמא[iii] והוא דר
בפתח שני שבו. אלהא דידן
ינהר מטוביה עלן[iv] ויפדה נפשנו
מעבור בשלח וחייתנו באור
תראה אכי״ר: [v]

the radiance of Moses our teacher's face, peace be upon him, explaining its origin.

And from the account written in the Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel, page 197,[1] it is evident that a person should hide himself when there is a plague[A] in the city, God forbid, and it [the Angel of Death] has permission to destroy.[2] They have already said, "When there is pestilence in the city, gather in your feet."[3] And they interpret this: "The way of an adulterous woman"—this refers to the Angel of Death, and thus it is called: "She eats and wipes her mouth" (Proverbs 30:20). It burns the world with its flames and kills people before their time has come, and says, "I have done no wrong,"[4] for it sought judgment against them because they were found with sins, and they died by righteous judgment. And it appears to me from the words of the Zohar that the Angel of Death emerges from the second chamber of the Exchanges [negative spiritual realms], which is called "impure destruction," and it dwells in the second entrance therein. May our God shine His goodness upon us,

[A] Or: "the Angel of Death (Samael)" — While the context clearly refers to epidemic disease, the Hebrew abbreviation שמ״ה likely refers specifically to Samael (סמאל), the Angel of Death. This is further supported by the Zohar passage referenced, which describes personified behavior. In many kabbalistic texts, the Angel of Death is directly associated with plagues and epidemics.

[2] The citation refers to the standard pagination of the printed Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism, which is organized following the weekly Torah portions.

[3] A significant concept in Jewish theology: destructive forces cannot act without divine permission. Even the Angel of Death operates within constraints established by God.

[4] This is a reference to the Talmudic dictum (Bava Kamma 60b) advising people to stay home during epidemics.

[5] The text portrays the Angel of Death as justifying its destructive actions by claiming it merely executes divine judgment against sinners, even when it appears to strike indiscriminately during epidemics.

[ii] This is an abbreviation for Samael (סמאל), the Angel of Death in Jewish tradition.

[iii] The text creatively reinterprets Proverbs 30:20, which originally describes an adulterous woman, as referring to the Angel of Death. This type of reinterpretation is characteristic of the midrashic and kabbalistic exegetical approach.

[i] This refers to specific chambers in the kabbalistic architecture of negative spiritual realms (קליפות/kelipot). According to this cosmology, the Angel of Death emerges from the second chamber in these negative realms, specifically from an entrance called 'impure destruction.'

[ii] The passage concludes with an Aramaic prayer asking for divine protection against the Angel of Death, reflecting the practical religious response to the metaphysical dangers just described.

[iii] Cf. Sefer Hasidim — The citation of Sefer Hasidim establishes this teaching as part of the Ashkenazic pietistic tradition, which often incorporated mystical elements while maintaining a focus on practical piety. The text uses this citation to provide an authoritative source for the belief that righteous individuals receive divine signs before death. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The citation of the Zohar grounds the teaching about the Angel of Death in the central text of kabbalah, giving it mystical authority. The Zohar often personifies spiritual forces, and here the author uses this reference to explain how the Angel of Death functions as a cosmic entity that executes divine judgment during plagues. | Cf. Proverbs 30:20 — The text reinterprets this biblical passage

and redeem our souls from crossing in Shelach[1] [a dangerous passage], and may our lives see light, 135R
Amen, so may it be His will.

פרק ט׳

Chapter 9

סדר וידוי לשכיב מרע[i] עם איזה חידושים השייכים עמו[ii] כאשר האיר ה׳ עיני[iii] כדי לזכות בהם את הרבים:[iv v]

The Order of Confession for the Deathly Ill,[A] with Certain Insights Pertaining to It,[2] as God Has Enlightened My Eyes,[B] in Order to Bring Merit to the Many[3]

[A] Or: "The Ritual of Confession for One on Their Deathbed" — This alternative more directly conveys the ritual nature of the text and the specific context of being on one's deathbed rather than merely being seriously ill. However, the term 'shechiv mera' has specific legal connotations in Jewish law that are better preserved in the original translation.

[B] Or: "through divine inspiration granted to me" — This alternative is less literal but may better convey to modern readers the concept of divine inspiration behind the author's insights. However, the original translation preserves the biblical imagery of enlightenment which has important kabbalistic connotations.

[1] The Hebrew 'מעבור בשלח' may be alluding to a dangerous crossing or passage, possibly referencing the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Yabok), which uses the metaphor of a river crossing for the transition from life to death.

[2] The author distinguishes between the traditional confession text (likely drawing on Nachmanides) and his own kabbalistic interpretations and additions.

[1] The concept of 'bringing merit to the many' (zikui ha-rabim) was considered one of the highest

about an adulterous woman as a metaphor for the Angel of Death, suggesting that just as the woman denies wrongdoing after her sin, the Angel of Death claims innocence after destroying lives, asserting it was merely executing divine judgment. | Cf. Psalm 104:29 — The author creatively reinterprets this psalm verse, which typically refers to God taking away breath/spirit causing death, to suggest that the radiance seen on the righteous before death represents an addition of spiritual purity just before expiration—inverting the usual meaning to suggest death as spiritual elevation. | Cf. Gaon of Fano (Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano) — The author refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an important Italian kabbalist, as 'my teacher,' suggesting a direct or intellectual lineage. The reference to Moses' radiant face (Exodus 34:29-35) creates a parallel between the divine radiance seen on the pious man before death and the luminous face of Moses after divine encounter.

[iv] Vidui (confession) was considered essential for a proper death in Jewish tradition. The term 'shechiv mera' (שכיב מרע) is Aramaic for 'one who lies ill' and has specific legal connotations in Jewish law regarding the validity of deathbed declarations.

[v] The author distinguishes between the traditional confession liturgy he will present and his own 'chidushim' (innovative interpretations or insights), reflecting the rabbinic value of balancing tradition with thoughtful innovation.

[vi] This phrase reflects the kabbalistic concept that mystical insights are received through divine illumination rather than merely intellectual effort, positioning the author as a channel for divine wisdom rather than its originator.

[i] This reflects the Jewish concept of 'zikui ha-rabim' (bringing merit to many), which was considered one of the highest spiritual virtues. By sharing his divinely inspired insights, the author helps others fulfill the mitzvah of proper confession, thereby accruing merit both for himself and for those who benefit from his work.

[ii] Cf. Masechet Semachot — The author draws on this text as a primary source for deathbed confession practices, establishing traditional authority for the rituals he presents | Cf. Zohar — The author bases his kabbalistic understanding of confession on Zoharic teachings about spiritual purification and the soul's journey after death | Cf. Ramban (Nachmanides) — The author acknowledges Ramban as a primary source for the traditional confession text he will present, establishing its authenticity and religious authority

במסכת שמחות כך כתיב[i] נוטה למיתה אומרים לו התודה שהרבה התודו ולא מתו והרבה לא התודו ומתו והרבה הולכים על רגליהם בשוק ומתודים ובזכות שהתודה תחיה וכו׳.[ii] לא דברים מחיים ולא דברים ממיתים שמא הלויתי או שמא הלווך אדם. שמא הפקדת אצל בני אדם או שמא הפקידו אצלך. עוד כתוב בספרי כל המתים טעונים ודוי שנאמר ואשמה הנפש ההיא והתודה וגו׳.[iii] אמרו רז״ל שעכן בא לעולם הבא מפני שהתודה[iv] וברבה דף קצ״ד שערי תפלה לעולם נפתחים ובפרט לחולה שה׳ סועד אותו ולא תהיה תפלתו עקרה אלא תהא עולה ותעשה פירות כדאמר אבא יודן לחכמי ישראל ברבה פרשת ראה ובירושלמי במסכת הוריות. וכתוב בספר הזהר פרשת נשא דף קכ״ג דתשובה מעליא כד אתמסר נפשא לגבה ועייל לה בזמנא דאיהי בתשובה.

In Masechet Semachot it is written thus: "For one who is approaching death, we say to him, 'Confess,' for many have confessed and did not die,[1] and many did not confess and died, and many walk on their feet in the marketplace and confess, and by the merit of your confession, you may live, etc." [Confession] is not something that sustains life nor something that causes death. [Ask him:] "Perhaps you have lent money to someone or perhaps someone has lent to you?[2] Perhaps you have deposited something with others or perhaps others have deposited something with you?" It is further written in the Sifrei: "All who die require confession, as it is said, 'When that person becomes guilty, he shall confess...'" Our Sages of blessed memory said that Achan merited the World to Come because he confessed. And in Rabbah, page 194, [it states that] the gates of prayer are always open, especially for the sick person whom God sustains, and his prayer will not be barren but will ascend and bear fruit, as Abba Yudan said to the Sages of Israel in Rabbah, Parashat Re'eh, and in the Jerusalem Talmud in Tractate Horayot. And it is written in the Book of the Zohar, Parashat Naso, page 123, that "superior repentance is when the soul is delivered to it[3] and enters it at the time when it is in a state of repentance. Then everything is rectified

spiritual virtues in Judaism. The author views his work as a means of helping others properly prepare for death, thereby accumulating merit both for himself and for those who benefit from his guidance.

[2]This passage establishes an important theological principle that confession (vidui) is not an admission of imminent death, but rather a spiritual practice that could potentially lead to healing. The text deliberately addresses the common fear that confession might hasten death by clarifying that it is neither life-sustaining nor death-causing in itself.

[3]These questions reveal the practical aspect of deathbed confession, focusing on resolving outstanding financial and interpersonal matters. This demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok approaches death preparation as requiring both spiritual and worldly reconciliation.

[1]This mystical description from the Zohar presents repentance at the time of death as having extraordinary cosmic significance. The cryptic phrasing refers to the soul entering into a state of repentance that creates spiritual rectification across multiple worlds.

[iii]The author references Masechet Semachot (Tractate Joys), which despite its name actually deals with laws of mourning. It is sometimes called Evel Rabbati (Great Mourning) and is considered a minor tractate from the post-Talmudic period that collects various funeral and mourning traditions.

[iv]The phrase 'etc.' (וכו׳) indicates the author is abbreviating the quoted text. The original continues with instructions not to allow the ill person to think confession hastens death.

[v]This is a reference to Numbers 5:6-7, which discusses the requirement of confession when a person commits certain sins. The full verse reads: 'When a man or woman commits any of the sins against man to commit treachery against God, and that person is [found] guilty, they shall confess the sin which they committed.'

[i]Achan, who is referenced here, was put to death for taking forbidden spoils during the conquest of Jericho (Joshua 7). His confession before execution, according to this rabbinic interpretation, earned him a place in the World to Come despite his punishment in this world.

בדין כלא אתתקן לעילא ותתא
הוא וכל עלמא. ואם יש טינא
בלבו על חברו החכם המודה
אותו או איש חשוב שדבריו
35 נשמעים לו שימצא שם ישתדל
עמו שיעביר רעה וכעס מלבו כי
כל העובר על מדותיו מעבירים
לו על כל פשעיו[i] ויתקן כל מין
דררא דממונא שיהיה לו עם שום
40 אדם קודם הודוי ויזהירנו החכם
על זה ואם צריך לכך יודיעוהו
טעם וכונת הודוי:[ii]

above and below—he himself and the entire world." And if he harbors ill will in his heart against his fellow, the sage who is helping him confess, or any respected person whose words are listened to who might be present, should make an effort to help him remove evil and anger from his heart, for whoever overcomes his natural tendencies, all his transgressions are overlooked.[1] And he should resolve any monetary matters he may have with any person before confession, and the sage should warn him about this, and if necessary, explain to him the reason for and purpose of confession.

35R

40R

כתב הרמב"ן סדר ודוי של
ש"מ[iii] כן קבלנו מחסידים ואנשי
45 מעשה[iv] וזה נסחו ראוי לכל ש"מ
שיעשה צוואה ויבקש מחילה
לכל מי שחטא ויבקש מרבים
שיעזרוהו בתפלה ויעשה תשובה
שלימה ויפול ידיו ויתעטף
50 בציצית.[v] ויאמר ה' אלהים

Ramban wrote the order of confession for a deathly ill person (shechiv mera),[2] which we received thus from pious individuals and people of good deeds. This is its text:[3] It is appropriate for every deathly ill person to make a will, seek forgiveness from everyone against whom he has sinned, request that many assist him with prayer, make complete repentance, drop his hands,[4] and wrap himself in tzitzit. He should say:

45R

50R

[2]This refers to the spiritual merit of forgoing one's natural desire for revenge or holding grudges. The text emphasizes that forgiveness of others at the end of life is particularly powerful for securing divine forgiveness of one's own transgressions.

[3]The term 'shechiv mera' (abbreviated as ש"מ in the original) is an Aramaic legal term referring specifically to someone on their deathbed, whose legal status differs from both healthy individuals and those with non-life-threatening illnesses.

[1]The passage ends here but would have been followed by the actual confession text. The formulaic ending indicates that what follows is a direct quotation of the confession that should be recited.

[2]This likely refers to a gesture of submission or surrender, symbolizing the relinquishing of worldly concerns and submission to divine judgment.

[ii]This is a reference to a Talmudic teaching (Rosh Hashanah 17a) that states: 'Whoever foregoes his natural reactions [to being wronged] will have all his transgressions forgiven.' The concept emphasizes the spiritual value of forgiveness and not holding grudges.

[iii]Cf. Masechet Semachot — This tractate (also known as Evel Rabbati) focuses on laws of mourning and death. The quotation provides the halakhic basis for deathbed confession, emphasizing that confession is spiritually beneficial but not deterministic of physical outcomes. | Cf. Sifrei — This midrashic work links confession to the biblical verse in Numbers 5:6-7 about guilt offerings, establishing a textual basis for the practice of confession before death. | Cf. Zohar — This kabbalistic text elevates the concept of deathbed confession beyond mere ritual to a cosmic act that has spiritual impact across multiple worlds and realms. | Cf. Story of Achan — This biblical reference to Achan, who confessed to stealing forbidden spoils from Jericho before his execution, is used to demonstrate that confession has merit for the World to Come even when it cannot save one's physical life.

[iv]Ramban (Rabbi Moses ben Nachman, 1194-1270), also known as Nachmanides, was a prominent Spanish Talmudist, kabbalist, and Torah commentator. Here, Ma'avar Yabok cites his instructions regarding the deathbed confession ritual.

[i]The phrase "pious individuals and people of good deeds" is a traditional way of referring to exemplary religious figures whose practices establish authoritative customs. Citing them lends weight to the ritual instructions that follow.

[ii]The physical gestures prescribed—dropping the hands and wrapping in tzitzit (ritual fringes)—create a bodily dimension to the spiritual preparation for death. The wrapping in tzitzit specifically connects the dying person to the commandments they observed in life.

אמת ותורתו אמת ומשה נביאו אמת[i] וברוך שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד ויקרא אשרי יושבי ביתך עד סוף המזמור. ומזמור תפלה לדוד הטה ה׳ אזנך סימן פ״ו[ii] ויאמר בקראי ענני סימן ד׳: שיר למעלות אשא עיני קכ״א: ויאמר אח״כ ודוי של ש״מ בכוונה גדולה וכן קבלנוהו מחסידים ואנשי מעשה וזה נסחו:[iii]

"The Lord God is truth,[5] and His Torah is truth, and Moses His prophet is truth," and "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever." He should recite "Happy are those who dwell in Your house" until the end of the psalm. And Psalm 86, "A prayer of David. Incline Your ear, O Lord," and he should say Psalm 4, "Answer me when I call," and Psalm 121, "A song of ascents. I lift up my eyes." Afterward, he should recite the confession for a deathly ill person with great intention,[1] as we received it from pious individuals and people of good deeds. This is its text:

מוֹדֶה אֲנִי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי אֱלֹהֵי אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק וְיַעֲקֹב אֱלֹהֵי הָאֱלֹהִים וַאֲדוֹנֵי הָאֲדוֹנִים[iv] בַּשָּׁמַיִם מִמַּעַל וְעַל הָאָרֶץ מִתַּחַת אֵין עוֹד. עוֹשֶׂה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ. עוֹשֶׂה חֶסֶד מִשְׁפָּט וּצְדָקָה בָּאָרֶץ. חָיָה וְחַוָּה וְיִהְיֶה. מְהַוֶּה אֶת הַכֹּל. שֶׁרְפּוּאָתִי בְיָדֶךָ וּמִיתָתִי בְּיָדֶךָ. יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהַי וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתַי שֶׁתִּרְפָּאֵנִי רְפוּאָה שְׁלֵמָה כִּי אַתָּה אֵל רוֹפֵא רַחֲמָן. וְאִם בַּר מִינָן אָמוּת[v] תְּהֵא מִיתָתִי כַּפָּרָה עַל כָּל חַטֹּאתַי וַעֲוֹנוֹתַי וּפִשָּׁעַי שֶׁחָטָאתִי וְשֶׁעָוִיתִי וְשֶׁפָּשַׁעְתִּי לְפָנֶיךָ. וְתֵן חֶלְקִי

I acknowledge before You, LORD my God and God of my fathers, God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, God of gods and Lord of lords, in heaven above and on earth below, there is none else. Maker of heaven and earth. Who performs kindness, justice, and righteousness on earth. Who was, is, and will be. Who brings all into existence. That my healing is in Your hand and my death is in Your hand. May it be Your will, LORD my God and God of my fathers, that You heal me with complete healing, for You are God, a compassionate healer. And if, God forbid, I should die, may my death be an atonement for all my sins, iniquities, and transgressions that I have sinned, transgressed, and rebelled before You. Grant me my portion in Your Torah and in the Garden of

[3]This threefold declaration of truth regarding God, Torah, and Moses represents a final affirmation of faith, establishing the dying person's spiritual standing before their departure.

[4]The Hebrew term 'kavvanah' (intention) refers to focused mental concentration and spiritual devotion during prayer, considered especially important during deathbed rituals when the person's spiritual state is believed to affect their soul's journey after death.

[iii]This threefold affirmation of truth resembles the recitation of the Shema, traditionally considered the ideal final words before death. It affirms the three foundational elements of Jewish faith: God, Torah, and prophetic revelation.

[iv]The notation "סימן פ״ו" refers to Psalm 86, indicating that the full psalm should be recited. This system of referencing psalms by their numbers was common in liturgical texts.

[v]Cf. Ramban (Nachmanides) — The author explicitly attributes this deathbed ritual procedure to Ramban, positioning it as an authoritative halakhic tradition passed down through generations of pious practitioners rather than a novel innovation. | Cf. Psalm 84:5 — This psalm verse establishes a tone of divine protection and blessing, appropriate for someone seeking spiritual comfort at the end of life. | Cf. The Shema declaration — This affirmation of faith functions similarly to reciting the Shema, which Jewish tradition prescribes as the ideal final words before death, creating a connection between the dying person and foundational Jewish beliefs.

[i]This phrase, 'God of gods and Lord of lords,' comes from Deuteronomy 10:17, establishing the confession's biblical foundation.

[ii]The Aramaic phrase 'bar minan' (literally 'outside of us') is an apotropaic formula to ward off the negative thing being mentioned (in this case, death). Its use here shows the careful balance between preparing for death while still hoping for life.

בְּתוֹרָתְךָ וּבְנֵן עֵדֶן וְזַכֵּנִי לְעוֹלָם הַבָּא הַצָּפוּן לַצַּדִּיקִים. וַאֲנִי מוֹדֶה וּמַאֲמִין כִּי אַתָּה נִמְצָא מְצִיאוּת גְּמוּרָה. וְאַתָּה אֶחָד וְלֹא כְּמִכְלָל הָאֲחָדִים. וְרֹאשׁ לְכָל הַנִּמְצָאִים. וְאֵינְךָ גוּף וְלֹא כֹּחַ בְּגוּף. וְלֹא יַשִּׂיגוּךָ מַשִּׂיגֵי הַגּוּף וּמְקָרָיו, וְאֵין בְּךָ דָּבָר מִתּוֹאֲרֵי הַגּוּפִים. וְאַתָּה קַדְמוֹן לְכָל הַנִּמְצָאִים. וְאַתָּה רָאוּי לְהֵעָבֵד וּלְהָרֵים. וְאַתָּה הַנּוֹתֵן נְבוּאָה בְּפִי כָּל הַנְּבִיאִים. וּנְבוּאַת מֹשֶׁה עַבְדְּךָ נְבִיאֶךָ לְמַעְלָה מִכָּל הַנְּבִיאִים.[i] וְאַתָּה נָתַתָּ לָנוּ עַל יָדוֹ מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם תּוֹרָה שְׁלֵמָה וּמְשִׁיבַת נָפֶשׁ. וְהִיא זֹאת הַתּוֹרָה הַקְּדוֹשָׁה הַמְצוּיָה בֵּינֵינוּ. וְהַגִּיעָה אֵלָיו מִפִּי הַגְּבוּרָה. וְלֹא תִהְיֶה זֹאת הַתּוֹרָה נֶעְדֶּרֶת וְלֹא נְסוּחָה: וְאַתָּה יוֹדֵעַ מַחְשְׁבוֹת בְּנֵי אָדָם וְלֹא תִתְרַשֵּׁל בָּהֶם. וְדַרְכְּךָ לְגָמוֹל טוֹב לַצַּדִּיקִים. וּלְהַעֲנִישׁ לָרְשָׁעִים. וְתָבִיא מְשִׁיחֵנוּ הָאָהוּב וּתְחַיֵּה מֵתֵינוּ: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי:[ii]

Eden,[2] and privilege me with the World to Come that is reserved for the righteous. I acknowledge and believe that You exist with absolute existence.[1] And 80R
You are One, unlike any other oneness.[2] And You are the First of all existences. You are neither a body nor a physical force. You cannot be apprehended by physical perception or its attributes, and nothing of physical characteristics applies to You. You 85R
are prior to all existences. You alone are worthy of worship and exaltation. You are the One who grants prophecy to all prophets. And the prophecy of Moses Your servant, Your prophet, is above all prophets. You gave us through him from heaven a 90R
complete Torah that restores the soul. And this is the holy Torah that exists among us. It came to him from the mouth of the Almighty. This Torah shall never be missing nor removed. You know the thoughts of human beings and are not negligent with 95R
them. Your way is to reward the righteous and punish the wicked. You will bring our beloved Messiah and revive our dead. May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer. 100R

ואם השעה דחוקה עליו[iii] יזקוף

And if time is pressing upon him,[A] he should raise

[A] Or: "And if his condition is urgent" — This alternative emphasizes the medical condition of

[1] This request combines the twin afterlife aspirations in Jewish tradition: continued connection to Torah study (intellectual/spiritual) and enjoyment of Gan Eden (reward/pleasure).

[2] The Hebrew 'מְצִיאוּת גְּמוּרָה' is a philosophical term reflecting Maimonides' view of God's necessary existence, contrasted with the contingent existence of created beings.

[3] This statement reflects the kabbalistic concept that God's unity is fundamentally different from mathematical oneness, being complete and indivisible rather than a unit that can be multiplied or divided.

[iii] This statement about the superiority of Moses' prophecy corresponds to the seventh of Maimonides' Thirteen Principles of Faith, showing how this confession incorporates core theological doctrine.

[i] Cf. Mishneh Torah by Maimonides — This confession closely follows Maimonides' formulation of essential Jewish beliefs, particularly regarding God's incorporeality, unity, and the superiority of Mosaic prophecy, showing that this deathbed confession was designed to affirm core theological principles before death. | Cf. Yom Kippur Liturgy — By incorporating language from the Day of Atonement liturgy, this deathbed confession connects the individual's final moments to the annual communal day of forgiveness, suggesting that proper death preparation serves as a personal Yom Kippur. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — This psalm verse, traditionally used to conclude the Amidah prayer, serves here to frame the deathbed confession as a formal liturgical act, connecting the dying person's final words to the daily prayers of the living community.

[ii] This phrase indicates that the author is providing an abbreviated alternative for when the dying person is unable to recite the full confession due to their deteriorating condition or imminent death.

ויאמר:[ii] [i]ונושא את עשר אצבעותיו כלפי מעלה his ten fingers upward[A] and say:

יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שֶׁיִּהְיֶה שָׁלוֹם מְנוּחָתִי:[v] [iv] רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם[iii] Master of the Universe,[B] may it be Your will that my rest shall be peaceful.[C]

ובמעמד ויחודו[vii] ויכוין בשם ית׳[vi] And he should focus his intention[1] on the Divine 105R

the dying person rather than the abstract notion of time, which might be more clear to modern readers unfamiliar with this euphemism for approaching death.

[B]Or: "he should lift all ten fingers toward heaven" — This alternative makes the religious nature of the gesture more explicit by using 'heaven' instead of the more directional 'upward,' emphasizing the spiritual dimension of this act.

[C]Or: "Sovereign of the World" — While 'Master of the Universe' is the most common translation, 'Sovereign of the World' captures the aspect of divine kingship and governance that is implicit in the Hebrew. This might be preferred in contexts emphasizing God's role as ruler rather than owner.

[D]Or: "peace shall be my repose" — This more poetic rendering emphasizes 'peace' by placing it at the beginning of the phrase, which might better capture the emphasis in the Hebrew where 'shalom' precedes 'menuchati.'

[1]The original term is "yekhavin" (ויכוין) from the root כ-ו-נ, which specifically refers to the Jewish spiritual practice of kavvanah—directed mental concentration during prayer. This is more than mere focus but a specific devotional technique.

[iii]This gesture has deep kabbalistic significance. The ten fingers correspond to the ten sefirot (divine emanations), and raising them symbolizes the soul's return to its divine source. When speech is no longer possible, this physical gesture serves as a non-verbal confession and declaration of faith.

[iv]Cf. Genesis 49:33 — The raising of ten fingers symbolizes surrender to God at the moment of death, similar to how Jacob gathered himself before dying. It represents a final conscious act of faith when speech is no longer possible. | Cf. Exodus 17:11 — The gesture of raising hands upward symbolizes complete reliance on divine assistance at a moment of extreme vulnerability, connecting the dying person's final moments to Moses' gesture of dependence on God. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 35 — This brief instruction is part of a larger system of deathbed rituals detailed in Chapter 35, where the author discusses the mystical significance of the soul's departure and how proper intentions facilitate peaceful transition.

[v]"Master of the Universe" is a common form of address to God in Jewish prayer, particularly in personal supplications.

[vi]This phrase "my rest shall be peaceful" refers to the soul's repose after death. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this short prayer appears as part of the deathbed ritual when the dying person is too weak to recite the full confession (vidui).

[vii]Cf. Full deathbed confession (vidui) — This short prayer encapsulates the essential spiritual attitude recommended for the moment of death: peaceful acceptance of divine judgment and hope for tranquility in the afterlife. It represents the minimum spiritual preparation necessary when a person is too weak for the full confession. | Cf. Genesis 49:33 — This prayer echoes the peaceful death of Jacob (whose crossing of the Yabok River gives the book its title). Just as Jacob completed his life's work and died peacefully, this prayer expresses hope for a similarly peaceful transition. | Cf. Psalm 31:6 — Though not directly quoting this verse, the prayer expresses a similar sentiment of surrendering oneself to God at the moment of death. This verse from Psalms is explicitly recommended elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation at the moment of death.

[i]The instruction to 'focus intention on the Divine Name' refers to the practice of kavvanah (directed concentration) during prayer, specifically directing one's thoughts toward the Tetragrammaton (YHVH). The abbreviation ית׳ stands for יתברך (may He be blessed).

[ii]This refers to the theological concept of God's absolute unity, a central tenet of Jewish faith. In Kabbalistic thought, meditation on divine unity is considered particularly powerful at moments of spiritual transition.

הר סיני הגדול והנורא:[i] ואחר סיום הודוי יאמר אל מלך:[ii iii]

Name,[2] His unity, and the great and awesome revelation at Mount Sinai. After completing the confession,[1] he should recite El Melekh (God, King).

פרק י׳

Chapter 10

נראה לי הדיוט הכותב כי טוב להשתדל עם החולה שישים לקופת הצדקה או לקופת חולים או יתן בידו לאיזה עני הגון קודם שיתחיל הוידוי לפחות עשרים וששה פרוטות.[iv] ואם יוסיף עד צ״א ליחוד הוי״ה ואדנו״ת[v] מה טוב. ואם יוסיף עד קי״ב כנגד הוי״ה אהי״ה אדנו״ת[vi] מה טוב ונעים והמוסיף מוסיפין לו חיים דבעובדא דלתתא אתער עובדא דלעילא ובדא אתער אילנא דחיי לאוספא להההיא אילנא

It seems to me, the humble writer,[2] that it is beneficial to encourage the sick person[3] to place at least twenty-six coins[4] in the charity box or patients' fund, or to give them directly to a worthy poor person before beginning the confession. If one adds up to ninety-one coins, corresponding to the unification of the divine names YHVH and Adonut, how good that is. And if one adds up to one hundred and twelve coins, corresponding to YHVH, Ehyeh, and Adonut, how good and pleasant that is. For one who gives more, more life is added, since through actions below, actions above are aroused, and through this the Tree of Life is awakened to add to the Tree of Death,[5] and

[2]In the Jewish tradition, the Divine Name (YHVH) is considered too sacred to pronounce. During prayer, focus on this name carries special significance, particularly at moments of spiritual transition like approaching death.

[3]The original text uses "vidui" (הודוי), which specifically refers to the ritual confession recited before death. This practice is considered essential for proper spiritual preparation and is mentioned several times in the Talmud.

[4]The phrase 'הדיוט הכותב' is a common expression of humility used by rabbinic authors, indicating the author's self-perception as an ordinary person rather than a great scholar.

[5]The original Hebrew uses the phrase 'להשתדל עם החולה' which literally means 'to strive with the sick person,' suggesting active encouragement rather than mere suggestion.

[6]The Hebrew term 'פרוטות' refers specifically to the smallest denomination of currency. In this context, the emphasis is on the number rather than the monetary value.

[1]This complex kabbalistic concept describes how divine mercy (Tree of Life) becomes activated through charity to balance divine judgment (Tree of Death), creating a state of cosmic harmony.

[iii]The instruction to contemplate the revelation at Mount Sinai creates a connection between the individual's deathbed confession and the paradigmatic moment of divine revelation in Jewish history. This elevates the confession to a moment of profound spiritual encounter.

[iv]"El Melekh" (God, King) refers to the beginning of a prayer known as "El Melekh Yoshev" (God, King who sits upon a throne of mercy), which is commonly recited before confessional prayers. It begins a sequence invoking divine mercy, appropriate after confession.

[v]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This reference connects to earlier sections of Ma'avar Yabok that detail the kabbalistic significance of the vidui ritual. Chapter 28 explains how proper intention during confession creates cosmic repairs in higher spiritual realms. | Cf. Zohar — The instruction to contemplate divine unity reflects Zoharic teachings that such meditations at the time of death facilitate the soul's peaceful transition and its reunion with its divine source. | Cf. Shulchan Aruch — Ma'avar Yabok's instructions align with halakhic requirements for deathbed confession while adding mystical dimensions that connect the practice to cosmic processes and divine revelation.

[vi]Twenty-six is the numerical value of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), the four-letter divine name. This establishes a mystical correspondence between the number of coins given and the divine name.

[i]Ninety-one is the combined numerical value of the divine names YHVH (26) and Adonut (65), representing the mystical unification of these complementary aspects of divinity.

[ii]One hundred and twelve is the combined numerical value of the divine names YHVH (26), Ehyeh (21), and Adonut (65), representing a more complete unification of divine attributes.

דמותא[vii] וכדין אשתכח חיים
וחידו לעילא. ובר נש דגרים
דא בשעתא דאצטריך ליה ההוא
אילנא דחיי קאים עליה וההוא
אילנא דמותא אגין עלוי וזהו יש
מפזר ונוסף עוד[i] עיין בחיי פ׳
בהעלותך דף קצ״ג ע״ב. ואין
לך דבר שעושה פירות למעלה
כצדקה הנעשית לשם יחוד ה׳
ובסתר ויכוין כי צדק יהיב
לצדקה ושמא קדישא אשתכח
שלים ובגינא דעביד לתתא הכי
אתער עלוהי ופי׳ עושה צדקה
בכל עת[ii] ירצה דכל רתיכין וכל
חילין כלהו אתברכן ואתוספן
נהורין כדקא יאות בגין דכלהו
אקרי ע״ת עיין פ׳ ויצא דף קנ״ג
ע״א. והעושה צדקה עובר בנהר
דינור בלא דחילו ויקום במקום
קדשו כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ מקץ וכן
אמרו רבנן על פ׳ וכן נגזו ועבר
ומזה בארוכה בפ׳ בחקותי דף
קי״א ע״ב וקי״ג ע״ב בפסוק
ונתתי גשמיכם. ואולי תועיל
הצדקה לכופר נפשו ע״ד מה
שכ׳ החכם ריקאנאט״י בפרשה
וירא כי בשנגזרה מיתה על
האדם ונמצא לו מלי״ץ אין תקנה
לדבר עד יתן כפרו. ומזה בזהר
פ׳ בשלח. והודוי עם היסורין
הוא המקובל ברצון. ואמרו
בויקרא רבה פרשה כ״ז על
פסוק צדקתך כהררי אל[iii] וגו׳

thus life and joy are found above. And when a person causes this at the time he needs it, the Tree of Life stands over him and the Tree of Death protects him. This is the meaning of "There is one who scatters and yet increases more"—see Bachya on Parashat Behaalotecha, page 193b. 15R

Nothing produces spiritual fruits above like charity given for the sake of divine unification and in secret. One should intend that Tzedek (righteousness) contributes to Tzedakah (charity),[1] and thus the holy Name is found complete. Because of what one does below, so is aroused above. This explains "One who practices charity at all times will be favored," for all the celestial chariots and hosts[2] are blessed and their lights increase appropriately, because they are all called "ET" (time)—see Parashat Vayetze, page 153a. One who gives charity passes through the River of Fire without fear[3] and will stand in His holy place, as we say in Parashat Miketz, and as the Rabbis said on the verse "So they are cut off and pass away," and this is explained at length in Parashat Bechukotai, pages 111b and 113b, on the verse "I will give you your rains." 20R 25R 30R 35R

Perhaps charity will serve as ransom for one's soul, according to what the sage Recanati wrote in Parashat Vayera, that when death is decreed upon a person and an advocate is found for him, there is no remedy until he gives his ransom. This is also found in the Zohar, Parashat Beshalach. Confession accompanied by suffering is favorably received. And they said in Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 27, on the verse "Your righteousness is like the mighty moun- 40R 45R

[2]This is a wordplay in Hebrew between 'צדק' (righteousness) and 'צדקה' (charity), suggesting that the divine attribute of righteousness is activated when humans perform acts of charity.

[3]The terms 'רתיכין' and 'חילין' refer to different categories of angelic forces in kabbalistic cosmology that govern various aspects of creation.

[4]According to kabbalistic tradition, souls must cross the 'River of Fire' (נהר דינור) after death as part of the purification process. This passage suggests that charitable giving provides protection during this spiritual transition.

[iii]The Tree of Life and Tree of Death are kabbalistic metaphors for the divine structures of mercy and judgment. The author describes how charity activates the Tree of Life to mitigate the effects of the Tree of Death.

[iv]This is a quote from Proverbs 11:24, which paradoxically states that one who generously scatters (gives) will increase rather than diminish their wealth.

[v]This phrase alludes to Psalm 106:3, 'Fortunate are those who maintain justice, who practice righteousness at all times.' In kabbalistic interpretation, the practice of charity at 'all times' creates connections with the cosmic dimension of 'time' (ET).

[i]This is from Psalm 36:7, 'Your righteousness is like the mighty mountains.' The midrash interprets this as an analogy for charity's protective power.

מה ההרים הללו כובשים את
התהום שלא יציף את העולם כך
הצדקה כובשת את הפורענות
ובפרשה כ״ו וצדקתך אלהים
עד מרום[i] מי מעמיד העליונים
והתחתונים צדקה שעושים ביד.
הה״ד וצדקתך אלהים עד מרום.
ואמרו בירו׳ דקדושין הדא דאת
אמר דבעי מצוה אחת שיסייע לו
לכף זכות דוקא לעוה״ב אבל
בעוה״ז אפי׳ צד אחד מאלף
ממלאך אחד מלמד עליו זכות
הקב״ה מכריע לזכות דזכות כל
דהן מספקת. וכתב בעל יפה
מראה דזהו דוקא בדין פרטי
המתחדש על אנשים באקראי
בעלמא אבל בדין ר״ה נידון ע״פ
רוב המעשה. זכינו בזה שזכות
כל שהוא יש כח בידו להכריע
החולה לכף זכות ולהחיות
את נפשו ולהבריאו. ויכוין
בואתה צדיק על כל הבא עלינו
לעשות גופו מזבח כפרה לתקון
עליו ביסורין שסובל ומקבל
עליו באהבה וייחד אהבה רבה
באהבה זוטא[ii] ומשם תעלה אור
הלבנה העליונה להיות כאור
החמה[iii] כי נטהרת לבעלה בכח
הדין אשר דחתה ממנה עליו
לצרפו ולנקותו: [iv]

tains," just as these mountains hold back the deep from flooding the world, so does charity hold back calamity. And in chapter 26, "Your righteousness, O God, reaches to the heights"—who sustains the upper and lower worlds? The charity that people do with their hands. That is the meaning of "Your righteousness, O God, reaches to the heights." 50R

And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Kiddushin, that this statement that one needs a single meritorious deed to tip the scales in his favor applies specifically to the World to Come, but in this world, even if only one angel out of a thousand advocates in his favor, the Holy One, blessed be He, tips the scales toward merit, for any merit whatsoever is sufficient. The author of Yefeh Mareh wrote that this applies only to individual judgments that arise coincidentally in this world, but in the judgment of Rosh Hashanah, one is judged according to the majority of one's deeds. We have thus learned that any merit, however small, has the power to tip the scales[1] in favor of the sick person, to revive his soul and heal him. 55R 60R 65R

One should have in mind when saying "And You are righteous concerning all that has come upon us" to make one's body an altar of atonement, to be purified through the suffering that one endures and accepts with love. This unifies great love with lesser love,[2] and from there the light of the supernal moon rises to become like the light of the sun,[3] for she is purified for her husband through the power of judg- 70R 75R

[1]This reflects the rabbinic concept that divine judgment can be influenced by even small positive actions, particularly in this world where mercy may predominate over strict justice.
[2]In kabbalistic terminology, 'אהבה רבה' (great love) and 'אהבה זוטא' (lesser love) refer to different divine attributes whose unification creates cosmic harmony.
[1]This is a reference to Isaiah 30:26 and represents the restoration of the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah, symbolized by the moon) to her original glory, equal to the divine masculine (symbolized by the sun).

[ii]This is from Psalm 71:19, 'Your righteousness, O God, reaches to the heights.' The midrash interprets this as evidence that human charity sustains both upper and lower worlds.
[iii]These are kabbalistic terms representing different levels of divine love. 'Great love' (אהבה רבה) corresponds to higher divine attributes while 'lesser love' (אהבה זוטא) corresponds to lower attributes. Their unification creates cosmic harmony.
[iv]This is an allusion to Isaiah 30:26, 'The light of the moon shall be as the light of the sun.' In kabbalistic thought, this represents the restoration of divine feminine attributes (the moon/Shekhinah) to their original glory, equal to divine masculine attributes (the sun).
[i]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — The Zohar passage is cited as authoritative support for the teaching that charitable giving can serve as a spiritual ransom or protection against a death decree. This reference connects the practical act of giving coins with mystical concepts of divine judgment. | Cf. Parashat Bechukotai, Zohar pages 111b and 113b — This Zohar passage is referenced to elaborate on the spiritual mechanics of how charitable giving affects the upper worlds,

ment which she has pushed away from herself onto him, to refine and cleanse him.

פרק י״א

Chapter 11

זהו תמצית לשון ספר הזהר[i] בפ׳ בלק דף קצ״ה[ii] לרמוז הוידוי[iii] מלבד מה שכתוב בזה בפרשה ויקרא ובפרשה פנחס דף רל״א:[iv]

This is the essence of the language of the Zohar[1] in the portion of Balak, page 195, alluding to confession, besides what is written about this[2] in the portion of Vayikra and in the portion of Pinchas, page 231: 5R

כשאדם מפרט חטאיו נקרא חסיד דאתי לקבלא[A] תשובה ואפיק

When a person details his sins, he is called pious,[3] one who comes to receive repentance,[A] and

[E]Or: "one who is prepared to accept repentance" — The Aramaic 'לקבלא' can be interpreted particularly in relation to divine blessing symbolized by rain. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 27 — This midrash provides the theological basis for charity's protective power, using the metaphor of mountains restraining floodwaters to illustrate how charity restrains divine judgments and calamities. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Kiddushin — This reference is used to establish the halakhic basis for the author's claim that even a small merit can have disproportionate spiritual effects for the sick person in this world. | Cf. Bachya on Parashat Behaalotecha, page 193b — This reference connects the biblical proverb about gaining through generous giving to the kabbalistic understanding of how charity activates cosmic mechanisms that return blessing to the giver. | Cf. Recanati on Parashat Vayera — The author cites this kabbalistic authority to support the specific claim that when a death decree exists, charitable giving can serve as a necessary ransom to fulfill the requirements of divine justice. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayetze, page 153a — This reference elaborates on the cosmic effects of charitable giving, explaining how it activates and strengthens the celestial forces called 'ET' (time), creating a comprehensive spiritual blessing. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Miketz — This reference connects charitable giving to the mystical concept of the 'River of Fire' (Nahar Dinur) that souls must cross after death, suggesting that charity helps the soul navigate this spiritual challenge.

[2]The author uses the phrase "תמצית לשון" (essence of the language) to indicate that what follows is not a direct quote but a distillation of the Zohar's teachings on confession.

[3]The author is indicating that the Zohar discusses confession in multiple places, and that this summary draws primarily from the Balak portion but is supplemented by material from Vayikra and Pinchas as well.

[1]The text creates a paradoxical definition of piety—the very act of admitting one's sins transforms a person into a 'chasid' (pious one). This reflects the Zoharic view that confession itself is a spiritually transformative act.

[ii]The Zohar is the foundational text of Jewish mysticism, composed in the 13th century, containing mystical commentaries on the Torah. It is the central text of Kabbalah.

[iii]The citation refers to the portion of Balak, folio 195, in the standard printed edition of the Zohar.

[iv]The term "רמז" (remez) has specific significance in kabbalistic hermeneutics, referring to the allegorical or hinted meaning beyond the plain text—one of the four levels of interpretation in the PaRDeS system.

[v]Cf. Zohar, Balak 195 — The author is citing the Zohar as the authoritative mystical source for the kabbalistic understanding of deathbed confession that follows. This establishes that the teachings on confession are not the author's personal interpretation but are drawn directly from canonical mystical texts. | Cf. Zohar, Vayikra — The author indicates that the Zohar's teachings on confession appear in multiple sections, showing the importance of this theme throughout kabbalistic literature. The portion of Vayikra in the Zohar would contain material related to sacrifices and purification, connecting confession to these Temple rituals. | Cf. Zohar, Pinchas 231 — The author provides a precise citation to another section of the Zohar that discusses confession, demonstrating scholarly thoroughness and giving readers the ability to verify these teachings in the original source. This shows that the author is synthesizing material from multiple sections of the Zohar to provide a comprehensive view of the mystical significance of confession.

גרמיה מסטרא בישא[i] דהוה
בטנופת דיליה עד השתא והשתא
אתדבק בימינא עלאה דאיהי
פשוטה לקבלה ליה ולא תימא
דלא מקבל ליה קב״ה עד דיפרט
חטאוי מיומא דהוה בעלמא או
אינון דאתכסיין מינה אלא לא
צריך לפרשא בר אינון דאידכר
מינייהו ואי שוי דעתיה בהו כל
אחרנין אתמשכו אבתרייהו דהא
תנינן אין בודקין חורי הבית
העליונים[ii] שהם רמז לעבירות
המתכסים ממנו והם ודאי חורים
שחררום העכברים דרשיעי
אינון שמשכנם סביב לתיבה
עליונה[iii] בסוד מחלליה מות
יומת ולא התחתונים שהם רמז
לעונות ראשונים אלא כפום
חיזו דעינוי והכי תנן בנגעים
כ״ד אברים שאין מטמאין משום
מחיה[iv] דכתיב לכל מראה

he removes himself from the evil side in which he was immersed in his impurity until now. Now he cleaves to the supernal right,[A] which is extended to receive him. And do not say that the Holy One, blessed be He, does not accept him until he details all his sins from the day he came into the world, or those that are hidden from him. Rather, he need only specify those that he remembers,[1] and if he sets his mind on them, all the others are drawn after them.[2] For we have learned: "We do not examine the upper recesses of the house,"[B] which symbolize the transgressions hidden from him. These are certainly holes made by the mice, which are the wicked ones whose dwelling is around the supernal ark, in the secret of "those who profane it shall surely die." Nor do we examine the lower ones, which symbolize the early sins, but rather according to what his eyes can see. And thus we learned regarding skin afflictions: there are twenty-four limbs that do not become impure through a living tissue, as it is written, "according to all the appearances in the eyes of the priest,"[3] for

10R 15R 20R 25R

as 'to accept' rather than 'to receive,' suggesting a more active role in the penitential process.

[F] Or: "attaches himself to the supernal right hand" — In Kabbalistic terminology, 'ימינא' (right) often specifically refers to the right hand, which represents the divine attribute of mercy, making this translation more explicit about the mystical symbolism.

[G] Or: "We do not inspect the upper corners of the house" — The term 'חורי' can be translated as 'corners' rather than 'recesses,' which might better match the Mishnaic source being referenced regarding the inspection for chametz (leavened bread) before Passover.

[2] This teaching provides profound psychological comfort by establishing that complete repentance doesn't require perfect memory of all past transgressions. Instead, sincerely addressing remembered sins creates a spiritual effect that encompasses forgotten ones as well.

[3] The text presents a mystical principle of spiritual contagion or extension, where focusing on remembered sins creates a metaphysical effect that encompasses forgotten sins as well. This establishes that sincere but incomplete confession can still be fully effective.

[1] The text weaves together halakhic concepts from different domains (Passover preparations and skin disease diagnosis) to create a cohesive metaphysical teaching about confession. This demonstrates the author's technique of finding spiritual correspondences between seemingly unrelated areas of Jewish law.

[i] Literally 'he takes himself out from the evil side'—using spatial metaphors to describe spiritual transformation. In Kabbalistic cosmology, the 'evil side' (sitra achra) represents the realm of impurity, often associated with the left side, while the right side represents divine mercy and holiness.

[ii] This is an adaptation of a Mishnaic ruling about searching for leaven (chametz) before Passover, which states that one need not search in places where chametz is unlikely to be found. Here it becomes a metaphor for the confession process.

[iii] The 'supernal ark' likely refers to the divine presence or possibly the sefirah of Malkhut (Kingdom), the lowest of the divine emanations and the receptacle for divine flow. The metaphor suggests that sin creates destructive forces that surround and potentially damage the connection to divinity.

[i] Reference to laws of tzara'at (often mistranslated as 'leprosy'), where certain body parts are not subject to the same rules of ritual impurity as others. The author uses this as an analogy for certain sins being 'covered' by general confession.

עיני הכהן דכלהו אתמשכן אבתרייהו:[i]

all of them are drawn after them.

עוד במקום אחר אמר וכל חטאין ומומין דישראל קב״ה יהיב להו לרב החובל דנהיג כל ארבין לאטבעה לון בעומקא דימא[ii] וכל משריין דיליה מצולות ים אקרו דאינון מחכאן למתנן דלעילא ככלבי לקמי פתורא[iii] וכד קב״ה נטיל חובייהו דישראל המתודים בשבירות לב (כאשר ביארנו למעלה פ״ד ובהקדמת מעירי שחר שלנו) וזריק עלייהו כלהו חשבי דאינון מתנן ונבזבזן דאיהו בעא למיהב לישראל והשתא אעבר יתהון מינייהו ויהיב לון ומיד כלהו כחדא זרקין לון וגומר. וידוע שלשבעים שרים של מעלה יש בתוכם ארבעה שהם ראשים על כלם וארבעה

In another place it states that all the sins and blemishes of Israel, the Holy One, blessed be He, gives to the Chief Mariner who steers all ships to sink them in the depths of the sea.[1] All his hosts are called the "depths of the sea," for they await the gifts from above like dogs before a table.[2] When the Holy One, blessed be He, takes the sins of Israel who confess with broken hearts (as we explained above in Chapter 4 and in the introduction to our "Illuminators of Dawn"), and casts them upon these forces, they all think these are gifts and presents that He wishes to give to Israel.[3] But now He removes these sins from Israel and gives them to these forces, and immediately they all together seize them, etc. It is known that among the seventy celestial princes, there are four who are chiefs over all of them, and the four kings whom Abraham defeated[4] ruled over these princes. This is what our Sages of blessed memory explained regarding Babylon, Media, etc.

30R 35R 40R 45R

[2]This vivid metaphor describes a spiritual entity that controls forces of evil. In kabbalistic literature, particularly the Zohar, natural elements like the sea often represent spiritual realms where negative forces dwell.

[3]This powerful metaphor appears in several Zoharic passages to describe how forces of impurity eagerly await spiritual sustenance, similar to dogs waiting for scraps to fall from their master's table.

[4]This describes a mystical 'sleight of hand' where forces of impurity are deceived into thinking they're receiving something beneficial when actually they're being loaded with Israel's sins. This conception explains the efficacy of confession from a kabbalistic perspective.

[1]This refers to Genesis 14, where Abraham defeated four kings: Amraphel of Shinar, Arioch of Ellasar, Chedorlaomer of Elam, and Tidal of Goiim. The text interprets this historical battle as having cosmic significance in the spiritual realm.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Balak — The Zohar presents confession (vidui) as a transformative spiritual act that not only atones for sin but actually changes one's metaphysical location, moving the person from the 'left side' (associated with judgment and impurity) to the 'right side' (associated with mercy and holiness). | Cf. Mishnah Pesachim — The author adapts a halakhic concept (not needing to search every corner for chametz) into a mystical teaching about confession, suggesting that one need not recall every sin to achieve effective repentance. | Cf. Mishnah Negaim — The author uses the halakhic principle that certain body parts aren't subject to the laws of tzara'at as a metaphor for understanding which sins need to be explicitly confessed versus those that are automatically included. | Cf. Exodus 31:14 — The text recontextualizes this biblical phrase about Sabbath desecration into a mystical teaching about the cosmic consequences of sin, suggesting that transgressions create a space for destructive forces around the 'supernal ark' (possibly referring to the divine presence).

[iii]This metaphor portrays a powerful celestial entity called the 'Chief Mariner' who controls ships destined to sink in the sea. In Kabbalistic literature, this refers to Samael or similar forces who control negative spiritual entities.

[iv]The comparison of spiritual forces to dogs waiting under a table is a powerful metaphor that appears in multiple Zoharic passages, depicting how these forces eagerly await whatever falls to them from the divine realm.

מלכים שנצח אברהם היו מושלים
עליהם שרים אלו.[i] וזהו שפירשו
רבותינו ז״ל על בבל ומדי
וכו׳. והכל היה סימן לבנים וכן
הזכיר הנביא ישעיהו מלחמה
זו בפסוקים מי העיר ממזרח.
ומי שמבין דברי חכמים בנבזבזן
ומתנן שהיו לישראל בהר סיני
מרהב וס״מ עם דברי הזהר
פ׳ בלק דף קצ״ב על פסוק
ה׳ בצאתך ישמח ויגל מאד.
וכתוב בפ׳ פנחס דף רל״א מאן
דמפרש חובוי כל בי דינא בדלין
מיניה[ii] ועל דא אצטריך לבר נש
לפרשא חובין בכל שייפא ושייפא
מכל דעביד בפרט ובגין דבר
נש קריב לגרמיה לא אתדן על
פומיה ותו לא שביק למקטרגא
לאולפא עליה חובא מומא
דבבר נש יקדים ויימא ולא יהיב
דוכתא לאחרא למימר יתיה בדין
קודשא ב״ה מחיל ליה הה״ד
ומודה ועוזב ירוחם. ואפי׳
המהרהר בתשובה בעה״ז ולא
הספיק לעשותה עד דאסתלק מן
עלמא צדיקייא נחתי בגיניה גו
שאול ונטלין ליה וסלקין ליה
מתמן[iii] ואפי׳ צדיקים גמורים
נחתי תמן לשאוב משם כמה
חייבין בנזכר וזהו ועסותם
רשעים כי יהיו אפר תחת כפות
רגליכם שמתאחזים במדרגות
התחתונות של הצדיקים ועולים

All of this was a sign for the descendants, and thus the prophet Isaiah mentioned this war in the verses, “Who stirred up one from the east.” And one who understands the words of the Sages regarding the gifts and presents that Israel received at Mount Sinai from Rahab and Samael, along with the words of the Zohar in Parashat Balak page 192 on the verse “The Lord, when You went out, rejoiced greatly,” [will gain deeper insight].

It is written in Parashat Pinchas page 231: “Whoever details his sins, all courts withdraw from him. Therefore, a person must specify his sins in every limb, detailing everything he has done. Because a person is close to himself, he is not judged by his own testimony,[1] and furthermore, he does not allow the accuser to teach sin against him. The blemish in a person should be mentioned first by the person himself, not leaving room for others to speak of it. Then the Holy One, blessed be He, forgives him, as it is written, ‘He who confesses and forsakes will obtain mercy.’”

Even one who merely contemplates repentance in this world but does not manage to complete it before departing from the world—the righteous descend on his behalf into Sheol, take him, and raise him from there.[2] Even completely righteous ones descend there to draw out many sinners, as mentioned. This is the meaning of “you shall tread down the wicked, for they shall be ashes under the soles of your feet”—they cling to the lower levels of the righteous and ascend from Gehenna.[3] This is also the meaning of “for You will not abandon my soul to Sheol.” These are the two paths that Rabbi Yochanan ben

[2]This reflects the legal principle that one cannot be convicted by their own admission in certain cases, but in the spiritual realm, self-accusation through confession actually protects against external accusers.

[3]This describes a mystical rescue operation where souls of the righteous can descend into Sheol (the underworld) to retrieve souls that had intended to repent but died before completing the process. This concept provides comfort regarding deathbed repentance.

[1]This explains the mystical mechanism by which sinful souls are elevated from punishment: they attach themselves to the ‘spiritual feet’ of righteous souls who can lift them to higher realms.

[i]This refers to Genesis 14, where Abraham defeated the four kings: Amraphel king of Shinar, Arioch king of Ellasar, Chedorlaomer king of Elam, and Tidal king of Goiim. The text reinterprets this historical battle as having profound mystical significance.

[ii]This is a key Zoharic principle explaining the spiritual mechanism of confession: by articulating one’s sins specifically, the celestial courts are prevented from bringing those charges against the person.

[iii]This describes the mystical rescue operation where righteous souls descend into Sheol to retrieve souls that contemplated repentance but died before completing it. This concept provides comfort about the efficacy of deathbed repentance.

מהגיהנם[i] וזהו כי לא תעזוב נפשי לשאול והם שני דרכים שאמר רבי יוחנן בן זכאי לתלמידיו שלא היה יודע באיזו דרך היו מוליכים אותו ועד״ז פירשו מה שהיה מרע״ה מסיח עם נפשו ואומר נפשי להיכן את הולכת וכו׳.[ii]

Zakkai told his disciples he did not know which one he would be led on. According to this interpretation, they explained what Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, conversed with his soul, saying, "My soul, where are you going?" etc. 85R

פרק י״ב

Chapter 12

מכל הנדרש ראינו כי צריך כל אדם לחשוב ולפרט את עוונותיו לפני מלכו[iii] ובפרט בודוי ש״מ. ולכן בחרנו להוסיף על הנוסח הנהוג איזה עונות שבהם נכשלים רוב בני אדם ובזה יתעורר כ״א כפי מה שידע בנפשו באיזה פרט הוסיף לחטוא.[iv] ואמרו שבראות האדם יצרו תאב לעבירה אחת יותר מהשאר צריך להתגבר נגד הפכו ולעשות משמרת למשמרת

From all we have learned, we see that every person must contemplate and specify their sins before their King, particularly in the deathbed confession (vidui).[1] Therefore, we have chosen to add to the standard formula certain sins in which most people stumble, thereby awakening each person according to what they know in their soul—in which particular matter they have added to their sinning. And they [the Sages] said that when a person sees their evil inclination desiring one transgression more than others, they must strengthen themselves 5R 10R

[2]The Hebrew term 'vidui shechiv mera' (abbreviated as 'vidui sh"m' in the text) specifically refers to the formal Jewish confessional prayer recited before death. This ritual confession has a fixed liturgical structure but can be adapted to address individual circumstances.

[i]This describes the mystical mechanism by which sinful souls are elevated from Gehenna: they attach themselves to the 'lower levels' of righteous souls, similar to how the priestly garment's hem had bells that would 'elevate' those who touched them.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Balak — The Zohar passage provides the mystical basis for understanding confession as a mechanism that literally transfers sins from the penitent to spiritual forces that receive them like dogs waiting for scraps. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas — This source establishes the Zoharic basis for Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on detailed confession, showing that when one confesses their own sins in detail, spiritual courts withdraw their accusations. | Cf. Genesis 14 — The text connects Abraham's historical victory over four physical kings to a spiritual conquest over four celestial princes who rule over forces of impurity, suggesting that physical events in biblical narratives have deeper mystical significance. | Cf. Isaiah 41:2 — This reference connects the prophetic text about 'one from the east' (Abraham) to the mystical understanding of his victory over forces of impurity, showing how the author integrates biblical text with kabbalistic interpretation. | Cf. Proverbs 28:13 — This verse serves as scriptural proof for the kabbalistic concept that detailed confession leads to divine forgiveness by preventing spiritual accusers from bringing charges against the person. | Cf. Malachi 3:21 — The text reinterprets this verse to describe how righteous souls help elevate sinners from Gehenna by allowing them to cling to their 'lower levels' or spiritual 'feet'. | Cf. Psalm 16:10 — This psalm verse is interpreted mystically to support the concept that righteous souls can be rescued from Sheol through the intervention of other righteous ones who descend to draw them out. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — This self-reference to the author's other work shows the intertextual nature of his writings and indicates that he had previously discussed the concept of confession with a broken heart in that work.

[iii]This emphasizes the importance of specific confession rather than general acknowledgment of sin. The metaphor of standing 'before one's King' frames confession as a formal audience with the divine, requiring detailed accountability.

[i]The author suggests that people tend to have particular sins to which they are especially prone, implying a need for personalized spiritual work rather than generic confession.

לבל יכשל בו כי אולי שולח הנה
לתקן עוות ההוא[i] ולכן יצרו
מפתהו שיהיה נכריה עבודתו
באשר אשמה הנפש ההיא. ולכן
כל אחד יפשפש במעשיו וישיבם
אל לבו ויפרט חטאיו המוזכרים
לו בינו לבין עצמו אם לא יהיה
מאותם שבין אדם לחברו וגם
שעקר התשובה היא בעודו בבחו
כמ״ש בתיקונים דף ק״י ע״ב
על פסוק מפני שיבה תקום.
והבל הביא גם הוא מבכורות
צאנו ובג״ד וישע ה׳ אל הבל
מ״מ אפי׳ חרב חדה מונחת על
צווארו של אדם אל ימנע עצמו
מן הרחמים ויש קונה עולמו
בשעה אחת כר״א בן דורדיא
והדומים לו[ii] ואפי׳ עד דכדוכה
של נפש כתיב ותאמר שובו בני
אדם. דקב״ה עושה חסד עם בניו
ונוטל אדם את בנו והאבן בידו
פי׳ אדם העליון מבין מנוחה
לבניו ונוטלם ונושא אותם גם
כשפגמו מעשיהם באבן נגף אחר
התשובה. ואמרו בשמות רבה פ׳
כ״ה על פסוק ישוב ירחמנו וגו׳.

against its opposite and create a safeguard around a safeguard[A1] so as not to stumble in it, for perhaps they were sent here to correct that particular distortion, and therefore their inclination entices them to make their service foreign, as that soul is guilty.[B] Therefore, each person should examine their deeds, return them to their heart, and specify the sins they remember between themselves and God—if they are not among those between person and fellow—even though the essence of repentance is while one still has their strength, as written in Tikkunim page 110b on the verse "Before the gray-haired you shall rise." And "Abel also brought from the firstborn of his flock," and therefore "the Lord regarded Abel," nevertheless, even if a sharp sword is placed on a person's neck, they should not withhold themselves from [seeking] mercy, and one may acquire their eternal portion in a single moment, like Rabbi Elazar ben Durdaya[2] and those similar to him, and even until the crushing point of the soul,[C] it is written, "And He said, 'Return, O children of man.'" For the Holy One, blessed be He, shows kindness to His children and "takes His son though the stone is in his hand"—meaning the Supernal Man prepares rest for His children[D] and takes them and carries them even when their deeds

[A] Or: "fence upon fence" — The phrase 'משמרת למשמרת' is a rabbinic concept referring to creating additional protective measures around a commandment. While 'a safeguard around a safeguard' captures the meaning well, 'fence upon fence' is a more common translation in academic literature when discussing this rabbinic principle of creating protective boundaries.

[B] Or: "whereby that soul bears guilt" — This phrase echoes biblical language about guilt-bearing. The alternate translation more directly reflects the ongoing state of bearing guilt rather than simply being guilty.

[A] Or: "to the very extinction of the soul" — This Talmudic phrase refers to the extreme point of spiritual or physical suffering. While 'crushing point' captures the physical metaphor, 'extinction' might better convey the sense of complete spiritual depletion intended in this mystical context.

[B] Or: "the Primordial Adam prepares rest for His children" — In Kabbalistic terminology, 'אדם העליון' often specifically refers to the 'Primordial Adam' or 'Adam Kadmon,' the first spiritual

[1] This is a reference to the rabbinic principle of creating protective boundaries ('seyag') around commandments to prevent accidental transgression. The doubling ('safeguard around a safeguard') suggests creating multiple layers of protection against one's particular weaknesses.

[2] This refers to a famous Talmudic story (Avodah Zarah 17a) about a man who spent his life pursuing sin but achieved complete repentance in a single moment before his death. Upon his sincere repentance, he died immediately, and a heavenly voice declared he had earned eternal life. This story is cited as evidence that genuine repentance is effective even at life's end.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of tikkun (repair/rectification), suggesting that each soul has specific spiritual work to accomplish in this world, related to its particular weaknesses.

[iii] Rabbi Elazar ben Durdaya is a famous example from the Talmud (Avodah Zarah 17a) of complete repentance at the end of life. After living as a notorious sinner, he achieved such profound repentance that he died in the process and a heavenly voice declared he had earned eternal life in a single moment.

הקב״ה מוצא שאנו חייבים לו
כובשו שנאמר יכבוש עונותינו.
ברם אשרי המתגבר על יצרו
בשהוא איש.[i] ובפ׳ תרומה דף
ק״נ ע״א מתבאר מה דינו של
המהרהר תשובה ולא הספיק
לעשותה כנדרש למעלה כמו כן
המהרהר הרהורי מצוה אע״ג
דלא יכיל קב״ה סליק ליה
רעותיה כאלו עביד ושם ביאר ז׳
פתחי גיהנם ומהו צואה רותחת
ואוי לישראל מחללי שבתות
דאין להם מנוחה אפי׳ בשבת
ושבועה שמשביעים לנשמה קודם
בואה לעולם התחתון היא בפ׳
תרומה ד׳ קס״א ובפ׳ בא דף
מ״א. ובפ׳ מקץ דף ר״ד פי׳
למה לא ניתן רשות לאלישע
אחר שיעשה תשובה[ii] אבל לכל
אדם לעולם ימינו פשוטה לקבל
שבים ואפילו עליו נאמר כל
מה שיאמר לך בעל הבית עשה.
ובע״ה הוא הקב״ה בעל העולם
ועשה כדבריו חוץ מצא שאם
ח״ו יאמר צא ממחיצתי כדאמרו
לאלישע אחר אל תפנה לדברים
אלו אלא תכנס ואל תירא כי
ודאי יקבלו אותך. ואל יחשוב
אדם שהשאול בית מנוס לו ח״ו
ולומר כיון דאטרדוהו לההוא
גברא מההוא עלמא לתהני
מעלמא דין דהא כתיב בקין
דהוא קינא דמסאבותא וכ״ש
ברשעי ישראל ואם לא תטיב

have been damaged by a stumbling stone, after repentance. And they said in Exodus Rabbah, chapter 25, on the verse "He will return and have compassion on us," that when the Holy One, blessed be He, finds that we are indebted to Him, He suppresses it, as it is said, "He will suppress our iniquities."[A] But truly, fortunate is one who overcomes their inclination while they are still a person [alive]. And in Parashat Terumah, page 150a, it explains the status of one who contemplates repentance but does not manage to complete it, as mentioned above; similarly, one who contemplates thoughts of performing a commandment, even though they are unable to fulfill it, the Holy One, blessed be He, elevates their will as if they had done it. And there it explains the seven gates of Gehenna[1] and what "boiling excrement" is, and woe to the Sabbath-desecrating Israelites who have no rest even on the Sabbath. And the oath that is administered to the soul before it comes to the lower world is in Parashat Terumah page 161 and in Parashat Bo page 41. And in Parashat Miketz page 204, it explains why Elisha Acher was not given permission to repent, but for every person, His right hand is eternally extended to receive those who return, and even about him it was said, "Whatever the master of the house tells you to do, do it." And the master of the house is the Holy One, blessed be He, Master of the World, and do according to His words except for "go out"—for if, God forbid, He says "go out from My presence," as they said to Elisha Acher, do not turn to these words, but rather enter and do not fear, for they will certainly receive you. And a person should not think that

40R 45R 50R 55R 60R 65R 70R

manifestation in the process of divine emanation. This more technical term would be appropriate in an academic translation of mystical content.

[C]Or: "He will subdue our iniquities" — The verb 'יכבוש' in this biblical context (from Micah 7:19) is commonly translated as 'subdue' in most English Bible translations, which might be more familiar to readers.

[1]In Jewish mystical literature, Gehenna (the realm of purification after death) is often described as having seven levels or gates, corresponding to increasingly severe forms of spiritual purification needed for different categories of sins.

[i]This expresses the traditional Jewish preference for timely repentance during the prime of life rather than waiting until one is weakened by age or illness, though the text acknowledges that late repentance is still valuable.

[ii]Elisha ben Abuya (known as 'Acher' or 'the Other' after his apostasy) was a Talmudic sage who abandoned Judaism. According to tradition, he was denied the opportunity to repent. The text uses this extreme case to emphasize that ordinary sinners should never despair of being accepted in repentance.

לפתח חטאת רובץ[i] כי כאשר
יצא האדם מפתח עוה״ז אל פתח
בניסתו לעה״ב אחריו מיד שם
לפתח חטאת נקבה שהיא לילית
רובץ זכר ס״מ מזדמנים לו
לגבות עונו כפי כחם כמו שהוא
מתגרה ברעה על עונו להוסיף
עון על עון כך מתגרים עליו
כחות החצונים כי יצה״ר משיאו
לעשות חטא על חטא כדי לאבדו
אבוד על אבוד ואם ימנע רשע
גמור מחטא עוד תועלת ימשוך
לו. והראיה כי אליך תשוקתו
ותשוקה זו היא ראיה שבחטא
הרשע מועיל לחצונים ומוסיף
פגם ועונש על עצמו ואפי׳ יהיה
הרשע גמור בעומק הקליפות
הרבה עם כל זה ואתה תמשל בו
לא לבד בחלק לילית אלא אפי׳
תמשול בס״מ. וזה לפי שאין
לחצונים צורת אדם רק צורות
בנחש וגמל[ii] והצורה הזאת שיש
לרשעים גמורים ואפי׳ למ״ה
הכל עשוקה אצלו מן הקדש.
ולזה יש כח לכל צורת אדם
להכלל בטוב שים עינך על דבר
זה דעהו וזכרהו: [iii]

Sheol is a refuge for them, God forbid, saying, "Since they have driven that man from that world, let him benefit from this world," for it is written about Cain that he is "the nest of impurity," and all the more so regarding the wicked of Israel. And [it is written] "If you do not improve, sin crouches at the door"—for when a person exits the doorway of this world to the doorway of their entrance to the World to Come, immediately after them, there at the doorway crouches "sin" (female), which is Lilith, and "crouching" (male), which is Samael,[1] who present themselves to collect his sin according to their power. Just as he provokes evil upon his sin to add iniquity upon iniquity, so do the external forces provoke him, for the evil inclination entices him to commit sin upon sin in order to destroy him, destruction upon destruction. But if a complete wicked person refrains from sinning further, it will bring him benefit. And the proof is [the verse] "and its desire is toward you"—and this desire is evidence that through the wicked person's sin, he benefits the external forces and adds blemish and punishment upon himself. And even if the completely wicked person is in the deep depths of the husks [kelipot], nevertheless, "you shall rule over it"—not only over the portion of Lilith, but you shall even rule over Samael. And this is because the external forces do

[1] In Kabbalistic demonology, Lilith (female) and Samael (male) are often portrayed as demonic counterparts or partners who prey on human souls. This passage creatively interprets Genesis 4:7 by identifying 'sin' (feminine in Hebrew) with Lilith and 'crouching' (masculine) with Samael.

[i] This phrase from Genesis 4:7 (God's warning to Cain) is reinterpreted in a mystical context to describe what happens at death—sin, personified as demonic entities, waits at the threshold between worlds to claim unrepentant souls.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that demonic entities (the 'external forces') lack the divine image present in humans. The specific forms of snake and camel may relate to their biblical associations with deception and burden.

[iii] Cf. Tikkun Zohar — The text references the Tikkunei Zohar (a collection of mystical commentaries on the Zohar), specifically page 110b which discusses the verse 'Before the gray-haired you shall rise' (Leviticus 19:32). In its kabbalistic interpretation, this passage connects the concept of standing before elders with rising to repentance while one still has strength, before the weakening of old age. | Cf. Genesis 4:4-5 — The reference to Abel bringing offerings from his flock and God regarding him favorably draws directly from Genesis 4:4-5. In the mystical context of this passage, it's used to demonstrate that even imperfect offerings (like deathbed repentance) can still be accepted, though not as ideal as timely repentance. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 10a — The phrase 'even if a sharp sword is placed on a person's neck, they should not withhold themselves from [seeking] mercy' is a direct reference to a Talmudic saying in Berakhot 10a. In this context, it's being applied to encourage deathbed repentance, teaching that one should never despair of divine mercy, even at the final moments of life. | Cf. Story of Rabbi Elazar ben Durdaya — The reference to Rabbi Elazar ben Durdaya alludes to the famous Talmudic story (Avodah Zarah 17a) of a man who lived a sinful life but achieved complete repentance in a single moment before his death. This story is cited here to emphasize that sincere repentance is possible even at the very

not have human form, only forms like a serpent and a camel, and this form that complete wicked ones have, even the Angel of Death, is all seized by him from holiness. And therefore, every human form has the power to be included in goodness[1]—set your eye upon this matter, know it and remember it.

ועצה טובה לחולה שיתודה בעת שליטת מדת החסד בקר לאברהם[i] כי אז משמשות אותיות ראשונות מהי״ב הויות היוצאים מצירופי שם בן ד׳ אותיות כי חדש בגימטריא י״ב הויות ובכל שבוע מושפעת מאור הנכלל בג׳ הויות שהם בי״ב גבולי אלכסון ואות אחת משם הגדול מחיה את כלן וג׳ ראשונות מנוקדות בנקודת מלך והשניות של שבוע שני מהחדש מנוקדות בנקודת מלך והשלישיות בנקודת ימלוך. וג׳ של שבוע רביעית נקודות אולם שבא קמץ כאשר בא טעם כל זה בספרי המקובלים כי ימי השבוע רומזים למציאות

Good advice for the sick person is to confess during the time when the attribute of Kindness rules,[2] in the morning for Abraham, for then the first letters of the twelve Divine Names that emerge from the permutations of the four-letter Name are active. This is because the word "month" in gematria equals twelve Divine Names.[3] Each week is influenced by the light contained in three Divine Names that correspond to the twelve diagonal boundaries, and one letter from the great Name animates them all. The first three Names are punctuated with the vowel points of "melekh" (king), the second three of the second week of the month are punctuated with the vowel points of "melekh," and the third three with the vowel points of "yimlokh" (he shall reign). The three Names of the fourth week are punctuated with the vowel points of olam (world), sheva, kamatz, as explained in the

[1]This statement reflects the fundamental Jewish belief in the possibility of repentance for all humans, based on the idea that all humans are created in the divine image. The text contrasts this with demonic entities that lack this divine image (described as having forms like snakes and camels) and therefore lack the capacity for redemption.

[2]The original text bases this recommendation on the kabbalistic principle that divine attributes (sefirot) influence different times of day, with the attribute of Chesed (Kindness/Mercy) being dominant in the morning hours, making it a spiritually advantageous time for confession.

[3]In Hebrew, the word 'chodesh' (month) has the numerical value of 312, which the author connects to the 12 permutations of the Divine Name (Tetragrammaton) that correspond to the 12 months of the year.

end of life. | Cf. Exodus Rabbah 25 — The text explicitly references this midrash's interpretation of Micah 7:19 ('He will return and have compassion on us...He will suppress our iniquities'). The midrash teaches that God actively suppresses the record of sins rather than merely forgiving them, indicating a complete erasure of the spiritual effect of sin after true repentance. | Cf. Zohar Terumah 150a — The text directly cites this Zohar passage which discusses the spiritual value of even incomplete repentance. In kabbalistic thought, the intention or contemplation of performing a mitzvah has spiritual reality even if the physical action cannot be completed. | Cf. Story of Elisha ben Abuya (Acher) — The reference to 'Elisha Acher' (Elisha the Other) alludes to the tragic Talmudic figure of Elisha ben Abuya who became an apostate. The text uses his example as a contrast, noting that while even he was denied the ability to repent according to tradition, ordinary sinners should never despair of being accepted in repentance. | Cf. Genesis 4:7 — The quote 'If you do not improve, sin crouches at the door' comes from God's warning to Cain in Genesis 4:7. In this mystical context, it's reinterpreted to describe what happens at death—sin (personified as Lilith and Samael) waits at the threshold between worlds to claim those who die unrepentant.

[i]The phrase "morning for Abraham" refers to the kabbalistic association of Abraham with the divine attribute of Chesed (Kindness/Mercy) and the morning hours when this attribute is dominant.

ענפי הספירות[i] מחסד ולמטה
שהם סדר זמנים המתפשטים
מהם במלכות ושם נכללים כל
שנויי פעולות הזמנים מצד
הבינה המסדרת אותם. ובכל יום
משתמשות ב׳ אותיות מהג׳ הויות
של אותו שבוע אחד ביום ואחד
בלילה כי יש בג׳ הויות שש הין
לשש לילות וג׳ יודין וג׳ווין
לו׳ ימים ואותיות אלה מאירות
כלם אהדדי בשבת בסוד ג׳
סעודות לג׳ הויות והיא שביתתן
דכתיב וישבות ביום השביעי
שהיא נקודת מלכות עצמה והיא
באמצע בבחינתה למעלה מנצח
הוד חג״ת מנה״י נה״י אינו
תלתא יומי מקמי שבתא ממעלה
למעלה. וחג״ת אינון תלתא יומי
בתר שבתא כנזכר. ובזה יבאו
כסדר ימי השבוע יום ראשון
חסד, יום שני גבורה עד יום ששי
יסוד[ii] בו לחם משנה בסוד אור
ישר וחוזר[iii] והיום הוא קיבוץ
כ״ד שעות י״ב ביום וי״ב בלילה
רומזות לענפים המתפשטים
במלכות משש קצוות שעליה
הכוללים ד׳ תקופות היום ערב
ובקר וצהרים לג׳ אבות בסוד
יחוד קב״ה ושכינתיה בדרועא
דימינא בתפלת שחרית ובדרועא
דשמאלא בתפלת מנחה ובעמודא
דאמצעיתא בערבית. ודהע״ה
אמר חצות לילה וגו׳ שאז הוא
שעשוע השכינה למעלה[iv] עם

books of the Kabbalists.

The days of the week symbolize the existence of the branches of the sefirot from Chesed downward, which are the order of times that extend from them into Malkhut, where all the various temporal activities are included, arranged by Binah. Each day utilizes two letters from the three Divine Names of that week—one for the day and one for the night—since the three Divine Names contain six Heys for six nights, and three Yods and three Vavs for six days. All these letters illuminate each other on the Sabbath through the mystery of the three meals corresponding to the three Divine Names. This is their rest, as it is written, "And He rested on the seventh day," which is the point of Malkhut itself. It is positioned in the middle, just as above it is positioned between Netzach-Hod-Chesed-Gevurah-Tiferet-Malkhut-Netzach-Hod-Yesod, which are the three days before the Sabbath in ascending order. And Chesed-Gevurah-Tiferet are the three days after the Sabbath, as mentioned.

Thus, the days of the week follow in order: Sunday corresponds to Chesed, Monday to Gevurah,[1] and so on until Friday, which corresponds to Yesod, containing the double portion of bread in the mystery of direct and reflected light.[2] The day is a collection of twenty-four hours—twelve in the day and twelve in the night—alluding to the branches that extend into Malkhut from the six extremities above it, encompassing the four seasons of the day: evening, morning, and noon, corresponding to the three Patriarchs in the mystery of the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence—through the right arm in the morning

[1] This correspondence between days of the week and the sefirot (divine attributes) is fundamental to kabbalistic time-keeping, influencing when certain prayers, meditations, or spiritual practices should be performed for maximum efficacy.

[2] This refers to the Jewish practice of using two loaves of bread (lechem mishneh) on Sabbath, which the text interprets as representing the kabbalistic concepts of 'or yashar' (direct light flowing from God to creation) and 'or chozer' (reflected light returning from creation to God).

[i] This reflects the fundamental kabbalistic concept that time itself is structured according to the divine attributes (sefirot), with each day channeling a specific spiritual energy.

[ii] This correlates each weekday with a specific sefirah: Sunday with Chesed (Kindness), Monday with Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), Tuesday with Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), Wednesday with Netzach (Victory/Eternity), Thursday with Hod (Splendor), and Friday with Yesod (Foundation).

[iii] The double portion of bread (lechem mishneh) used on Sabbath is interpreted as representing the mystical concepts of direct light (or yeshar) and reflected light (or chozer), which are kabbalistic terms describing the dynamic flow of divine influence down to creation and the reciprocal elevation from creation back to divinity.

[i] This references King David's practice of rising at midnight for prayer (Psalms 119:62) and explains

שרשי נשמות החיים והמתים ג״כ כדאי׳ בפ׳ לך לך דף פ״ב אבל אינו זווג אלא הארת פנים וחדוש תורה כי מלכות או מציאות ת״ת שבמלכות תכנס בחצי הלילה בג״ע של מעלה בעולם הבריאה או היצירה שהוא ג״ע תחתון או העשיה ששם מדור הנפשות שבהם חוזרים ושובנים הנשמה והרוח והנפש כל אחד כפי מדרגתו ושם תתגלה השכינה ותאיר בהם אור ושפע מה׳. וגם בעת שהצדיק נפטר מן העולם תתיחד כ״י עם הת״ת ע״י נשמתו המסתלקת למעלה וגם זה יחוד הוא לא זווג אלא נועדים לקבל באהבה כשרון מעשיה ולעולם אין שפע וברכה שורה בעליונים ואין זווג לת״ת ומלכות במקומם אלא מצד התחתונים והזמנתם אשר הוא לעתים כגון בהגיע ש״ץ לשים שלום יום ויום דאז הוא הקמת הברית הנקרא שלום[i] והוא עת רצון ודאי. ואמרו במדבר רבה פרשה י״א אפילו אדם רואה בחלומו כאלו חרב מחתכת בירכו מה יעשה ישכים לבית הכנסת ויעמוד לפני הכהנים וישמע ברכת כהנים ואין דבר רע מזיקו. וכן בחג שבועות הזווג הוא כולי יומא וכיוצא. וזהו טעם לחם הפנים ושיור פתיתין על השלחן לאחר הסעודה למי שאי אפשר לו להכין בתחלת הסעודה בכבר שלם לברכת המזון

prayer, through the left arm in the afternoon prayer, and through the central column in the evening prayer.

King David said, "At midnight, etc.,"[1] for that is when the Divine Presence delights above with the root souls of the living and the dead, as stated in Parashat Lekh Lekha, page 82. However, this is not a complete union but rather an illumination of countenance and renewal of Torah, for Malkhut, or the aspect of Tiferet within Malkhut, enters at midnight into the supernal Garden of Eden in the world of Beriah, or Yetzirah, which is the lower Garden of Eden, or Asiyah, where the souls dwell. There, the Neshamah, Ruach, and Nefesh return and reside, each according to its level, and there the Divine Presence is revealed and illuminates them with light and abundance from God.

Similarly, when a righteous person departs from the world, the Community of Israel unites with Tiferet through his soul that ascends upward.[2] This too is a unification, not a complete union, but rather they meet to receive with love the excellence of her deeds. Never does abundance and blessing rest in the upper realms, nor is there a union of Tiferet and Malkhut in their place, except through the lower beings and their preparation, which occurs at specific times—for example, when the prayer leader reaches "Sim Shalom" each day, for then is the establishment of the covenant called peace, and it is certainly a time of favor.

They said in Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah, chapter 11: Even if a person sees in his dream a sword cutting his thigh, what should he do? He should rise early to the synagogue, stand before the priests, and hear the Priestly Blessing,[3] and no evil thing will harm

[1] This refers to Psalm 119:62, where King David states: 'At midnight I rise to give thanks to You because of Your righteous judgments.' In kabbalistic tradition, midnight is considered a particularly potent time for prayer and Torah study.

[2] This describes the kabbalistic understanding of what happens when a righteous person dies: their ascending soul creates a channel of connection between the feminine aspect of divinity (Shekhinah/Community of Israel) and the masculine aspect (Tiferet), facilitating divine union.

[1] The text recommends the Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim) as a protective remedy against negative dreams, highlighting the belief that certain ritual practices at specific times can counteract spiritual dangers.

its mystical significance as a time when the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) has special interaction with souls.

[ii] The prayer for peace (Sim Shalom) in the daily liturgy is identified as a moment of cosmic significance when the divine covenant of peace is established, creating an opportunity for union between the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity.

כמבואר בזהר פרשת יתרו. וכן סוד נביעת החלב בדדי המנקת שהתנוק הוא הגורם וטעם זה כי האור החוזר נעשה תיק וכסא ומכון שיתלבש בו אור עליון המתחדש תמיד.[i] הנה נרמז ריש מילין סוד הטיול לשכינה בחצי הלילה:[ii]

him. Similarly, on the festival of Shavuot, the union continues all day, and the like. This explains the purpose of the showbread and the leaving of bread pieces on the table after the meal for one who cannot prepare a whole loaf at the beginning of the meal for the blessing after meals, as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Yitro. This also explains the mystery of milk flowing in the nursing mother's breasts,[1] which is caused by the infant, the reason being that the reflected light becomes a sheath, throne, and foundation in which the ever-renewing supernal light clothes itself. Thus, we have hinted at the beginning of the words about the mystery of the Divine Presence's journey at midnight.

195R

200R

פרק י״ג

Chapter 13

עוד נעלה על ספר מה שביארו בבחינת זווג שהוא בח״ב ובת״ת ומלכות כמו שבא בספ״ר וכאשר הוסיף מדעתו הרחבה מורי הגאון מפאנו בספר העסים שלו.[iii] וזה כי במצות שעושים התחתונים נפתח להם משפע מת״ת שנשמתן נאצלת משם

I will further record what has been explained regarding the concept of union, which occurs in Chokhmah-Binah and in Tiferet-Malkhut,[A] as it appears in the Sefer [Yetzirah], and as my teacher, the Gaon of Fano, expanded from his vast knowledge in his book "HaAssis."[B] When the lower beings perform commandments, they are opened to receive an influx from Tiferet, from which their

5R

[A] Or: "in Chokhmah-Binah and in Tiferet and Malkhut" — The Hebrew abbreviations could be translated more literally by separating Tiferet and Malkhut, though the original translation better captures the paired nature of these divine attributes in the context.

[A] Or: "and as my teacher, the eminent Rabbi of Fano, added from his broad understanding in his book "HaAssis"" — This alternate provides a more conventional translation of 'Gaon' as an honorific title rather than preserving it as a transliteration, and translates 'mida'ato harechava' slightly differently.

[2] The text uses breastfeeding as a physical metaphor for a spiritual principle: just as an infant's suckling stimulates milk production, so too do human spiritual actions below stimulate divine response from above.

[i] This metaphysical explanation reveals how reflected spiritual light forms vessels that can then receive and contain new divine illumination, describing the reciprocal relationship between human spiritual activity and divine response.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Lekh Lekha — The Zohar passage explains how souls commune with the Divine Presence during the midnight hour, which supports the text's explanation of spiritual dynamics occurring at different times of day. | Cf. Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah — This midrash is cited as evidence of specific times when divine protection is available, supporting the text's broader argument about the importance of timing in spiritual activities. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Yitro — The Zohar reference provides the mystical basis for a common practice, used here as an example of how physical actions correspond to spiritual mechanics in the upper worlds. | Cf. Biblical account of Creation — The text interprets God's rest on the seventh day in kabbalistic terms, connecting it to the sefirah of Malkhut and explaining the mystical significance of the Sabbath within the divine structure.

[i] Rabbi Menachem Azariah of Fano (1548-1620) was a prominent Italian kabbalist and rabbinic authority, often referred to as 'Rama MiFano.' The author's reference to him as 'my teacher' establishes an important intellectual lineage.

וחוזר האור מן הנשמה למקורה
זה וזה דרך המלכות כטבע
הרוחניות המתרבה מאליו
והיא מתקשטת לעומת בעלה
מצרוף שני האורות יחד והן
מזדווגים במקומן באהבה
רבה ואינם צריכים לעלות
להיכל הבינה. ואיש ואשתו
בתחתונים להם דוגמא לאותיות
ו״ה מהשם[i] שאינם מתקדשים
בקדושת השם אלא בצרופם עם
י״ה ולכן בזווגם ובמצותיהם
צריכים להעלות נשמתם וכוונתם
לת״ת ומלכות שהם י״ה בערכה
להשלים השם למטה שכן אמרו
בזהר שארבעה אותיות השם
יש להם דוגמא בביתו של אדם
צדיק. ביה ובאנתתיה בבריה
ובברתיה[ii] אבל קודם יצירת
אדם וחוה לא היו ת״ת ומלכות
אלא במקום ו״ה בלבד מושפעים
ולא משפיעים ולהשלים להם
ההוי״ה היו צריכים לעלות אצל
אבא ואמא ומזווג ת״ת ומלכות
יתהוו הנשמות הקדושות. ויש
עוד טיול למעלה עם שרשי
נשמות הצדיקים החיים. וזה
בשעת נפילת אפים אחר חזרת
התפלה[iii] שקושר וחובק עצמו

souls are emanated. The light then returns from the soul to its source through Malkhut, like the nature of spirituality which multiplies of itself.[1] She [Malkhut] adorns herself before her husband through the combination of these two lights together,[A] and they unite in their place with great love, without needing to ascend to the palace of Binah. 10R 15R

A husband and wife in the lower worlds are analogous to the letters Vav and Heh of the Divine Name, which are not sanctified with the holiness of the Name except when combined with Yod-Heh. Therefore, in their union and in their commandments, they need to elevate their souls and intentions toward Tiferet and Malkhut, which are like Yod-Heh in relation to them, to complete the Name below. As they say in the Zohar, the four letters of the Name have their counterpart in the household of a righteous person:[2] in him, his wife, his son, and his daughter. But before the creation of Adam and Eve, Tiferet and Malkhut were merely in the position of Vav-Heh, receiving but not giving.[B] To complete the Divine Name for them, they needed to ascend to Father and Mother [Abba and Imma], and from the union of Tiferet and Malkhut, holy souls would be formed. 20R 25R 30R

There is also another spiritual journey above with the root souls of living righteous ones. This occurs during the Nefilat Apayim [falling on one's face] after the repetition of the prayer, when one binds and 35R

[B] Or: "She [Malkhut] adorns herself to face her husband from the combination of the two lights together" — This alternate translation more literally renders 'le'umat' as 'facing' rather than 'before,' emphasizing the face-to-face positioning that is significant in kabbalistic union symbolism.

[C] Or: "Tiferet and Malkhut were only in the place of Vav-Heh, influenced but not influencing" — This translation more literally renders 'mushpa'im velo mashpi'im' as 'influenced but not influencing' rather than 'receiving but not giving,' preserving the technical kabbalistic terminology.

[1] This describes a fundamental kabbalistic principle that spiritual energy, unlike physical matter, increases rather than diminishes when shared or transmitted. This concept underlies many mystical practices.

[2] The four letters of God's name (YHVH) are understood to be reflected in the four members of a family: father (Yod), mother (first Heh), son (Vav), and daughter (final Heh). This demonstrates how kabbalah sees human relationships as mirroring divine structures.

[ii] This presents a kabbalistic understanding of marriage where human couples mirror divine processes. The letters Vav and Heh of God's name YHVH represent the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity that find expression in human relationships.

[iii] In Aramaic: 'in him, in his wife, in his son, and in his daughter.' This establishes that a righteous person's household is structured to reflect the four letters of God's name, creating a microcosm of divine reality in human family life.

[i] Nefilat Apayim (falling on one's face) refers to a prayer posture of prostration or head-bowing performed after the repetition of the Amidah prayer. In kabbalah, this physical gesture corresponds to spiritual processes of ascent and unification.

כעין חבוק כי יכוין עליית היכלות היצירה עד היכל אהבה
40 דשם סוד החבוק. וגם הוא מחבק ידיו ומשם מכוין להעלות היכלות אל היכל הרצון בסוד אברים באברים ואח״כ מכניס רוחניות כולם אל היכל קדש
45 הקדשים והיינו התעוררות נביעו דדכורא בנוקבא והיא אושידת מיין נוקבין לקבלא מיין דכורין ופיו האומר התפלה בנשמתו אושידת מיין בסוד מסירת נפשו
50 מתוך הנקבה אל הזכר באליך ה׳ נפשי אשא להיות נכלל בתוך הנשמות הנשפעות ומתחדשות מלמעלה בסוד יוסף הצדיק למעלה הממשיך למלכות מיין
55 דכורין. ובנימין צדיק לתתא לעורר מיין נוקבין.[i] ושכינה שרויה בין שני צדיקים:[ii]

embraces oneself in an embrace-like manner. One should direct one's intention to the ascent of the Palaces of Formation up to the Palace of Love, where 40R
the secret of embracing lies. He also embraces his hands, and from there directs his intention to elevate the Palaces to the Palace of Will, in the secret of "limbs within limbs." Afterward, he brings
all the spirituality into the Holy of Holies. This is 45R
the arousal of the male flow into the female, and she pours forth the feminine waters to receive the masculine waters. His mouth, which recites the prayer, pours forth waters through his soul,[1] in the secret of
surrendering his soul from within the female to the 50R
male,[A] as in "To You, O LORD, I lift up my soul," to be included among the souls that flow and are renewed from above. This is the secret of Joseph the Righteous above, who draws down masculine waters
to Malkhut, and Benjamin the Righteous below, who 55R
stirs the feminine waters.[2] And the Divine Presence rests between these two righteous ones.

פרק י״ד

אחר שבארנו מהו טיול ושעשוע בחצי הלילה לתקופה רביעית

Chapter 14

Having explained the concept of spiritual journeying and delight during midnight in the fourth season

[A] Or: "in the mystery of offering his soul from within the feminine principle to the masculine principle" — This alternate translation renders 'sod' as 'mystery' rather than 'secret' and uses 'feminine principle' and 'masculine principle' for 'nekevah' and 'zakhar,' emphasizing the metaphysical rather than physical nature of these kabbalistic concepts.

[1] This metaphor compares prayer to pouring water, reflecting the kabbalistic concept that verbal prayer creates spiritual flows that affect higher realms. The imagery connects human devotional practice to cosmic processes of divine unification.

[2] Joseph and Benjamin, sons of Jacob and Rachel in the Bible, are reinterpreted as mystical archetypes representing two directions of spiritual energy flow: downward bestowal (Joseph) and upward arousal (Benjamin). This illustrates how kabbalah transforms biblical narratives into cosmic principles.

[i] The biblical brothers Joseph and Benjamin are interpreted as mystical archetypes representing complementary spiritual functions. Joseph channels divine energy downward (masculine waters), while Benjamin stimulates the upward flow of receptive energy (feminine waters). This reflects how kabbalah reinterprets biblical figures as cosmic principles.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The author is building his explanation of spiritual unions on a foundation from the primary text of Jewish mysticism, giving his interpretation authoritative weight. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The author acknowledges the ancient source of these concepts of union while also noting how they were expanded upon by later authorities like the Gaon of Fano. | Cf. Psalms 25:1 — This biblical verse is reinterpreted in a mystical context to describe the soul's ascent during prayer, particularly during the Nefilat Apayim ritual. | Cf. Rabbi Menachem Azariah of Fano's 'Sefer HaAssis' — The author acknowledges his intellectual lineage, showing how these mystical concepts were transmitted and elaborated upon by his teacher, who was a prominent 16th-century Italian kabbalist. | Cf. Joseph and Benjamin as mystical archetypes — This transforms biblical brothers into symbolic representatives of cosmic processes, illustrating how kabbalah reinterprets biblical narratives as mystical allegories for divine processes.

לדוד רגל רביעי. נחזור לבאר
סדר זמנים ולהורות טעם שליטת
החסד בבקר. והוא כי ענפי
השעות מאירים במלכות מינה
ובה בכ״ד צרופי א״ד מכוונים
לכ״ד צרופי הוי״ה[i] בהבחן ב׳
ההין גדולה וקטנה כל אחד
לעצמה ואותיות ההויו״ת מהם
זכרים בסוד אור ישר בעלי
רחמים כגון אותיות י״ו ומהם
נקבות בסוד אור המתהפך
שהוא דין וכן בשם אדנ״י
יבחנו אל״ף יו״ד מן הזכרים
ואילך מן הנקבות וכל אות
מן האלפא ביתא מצטרפת עם
כל אחד מארבעה אותיות השם
הגדול עם ששה נקודות שהם
קמץ צירי חולם חירק שורק
שבא כי התנועות גדולות שהם
רומזים למציאות הספירות
במקומן מספיקות לעצמן
וגם לקטנות שהם מציאותן
המתפשטות במלכות המשמשות
תחתיהן[ii] אבל שבא הגם שהוא
עבד עבדים פעמים עבד משכיל
ימשול בבן כגון אם בא בראש

corresponding to David, the fourth leg,[A 1] we will
now return to explain the order of times and
teach the reason for the dominance of Chesed 5R
(Loving-kindness) in the morning. This is because
the branches of the hours shine within Malkhut
from within it, and within it are 24 permutations of
Alef-Dalet[B] corresponding to the 24 permutations of
the Divine Name (YHVH),[2] distinguishing between 10R
the two Hei letters—the greater and lesser—each on
its own. Of the letters of the Divine Names, some are
masculine in the mystery of "direct light" possessing
mercy, such as the letters Yod-Vav, while others
are feminine in the mystery of "reflected light" 15R
which is judgment.[3] Similarly, in the name Adonai,
Alef-Yod are examined as being from the masculine,
and onward from the feminine. Every letter of the
alphabet combines with each of the four letters
of the Great Name along with six vowel points: 20R
kamatz, tzeirei, cholam, chirik, shuruk, and sheva.
The major vowels, which allude to the existence
of the sefirot in their places, are sufficient unto
themselves and also for the minor ones, which are
their extensions manifesting in Malkhut that serve 25R
beneath them. But sheva, although it is a "servant
of servants," sometimes "a wise servant rules over a
son," as when it appears at the beginning of a word,

[A] Or: "for the fourth time period [of the night], symbolized by David as the fourth support" — This is a kabbalistic reference to the four-part division of the night, with David representing the fourth division. The term 'regel' (leg) can also be understood as 'support' in this mystical context where David symbolizes the fourth position in a spiritual structure.

[B] Or: "permutations of [the Divine Name] Alef-Dalet" — In kabbalistic texts, 'א״ד' may specifically reference a divine name rather than just the letters. The original translation is accurate but this alternative clarifies the mystical significance.

[1] This opening refers to a previously discussed concept where the night is divided into four spiritual watches or periods, with the fourth being associated with King David. In kabbalistic tradition, David is often connected to Malkhut, the lowest sefirah that represents divine kingship.

[2] The text describes a system where the 24 possible arrangements of the letters in God's name (YHVH) correspond to 24 permutations of the letters Alef and Dalet. This represents the mystical mathematics through which kabbalists understood divine influence operating in different time periods.

[3] This reflects a fundamental kabbalistic principle that divine energy flows in two directions: a direct flow downward from God to creation (masculine, merciful) and a reflective flow upward from creation to God (feminine, associated with judgment). Even individual letters are categorized within this cosmic gender system.

[i] The text describes a complex kabbalistic correspondence between time divisions and divine names. The 24 permutations of Alef-Dalet (א״ד) are linked to the 24 permutations of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), establishing a mystical relationship between temporal cycles and divine attributes.

[i] This passage describes the kabbalistic understanding of vowel points in relation to the sefirot (divine emanations). The 'major vowels' symbolize the sefirot in their original state, while the 'minor ones' represent their extensions that manifest in Malkhut (the lowest sefirah, representing divine kingdom in the material world).

תיבה אז לגיון לבדו הוא. וכל
אותיות של אלפא ביתא היו כלי
אומנתו של שם הגדול במעשה
בראשית.[i] ויו״ד קמץ עם אל״ף
שש פעמים בשש נקודות וכן כל
שאר אותיות השם מספרם כולם
יחד תתר״ף שהם חלקי ורגעי
השעה ומלבד זה יש תתר״ף
באותיות השם לבד בלי סיוע
הנקודות. הנה ב׳ בחינות תתר״ף
וי״ב הויו״ת הם י״ב פעמים
תתר״ף לי״ב שעות מהיום.
ותשים אותיות השם תחילה
ואל״ף בסוף וההפך לי״ב שעות
והאותיות עם הכפולות הם כ״ז
כנגד כ״ז ימים שלמים שהירח
סובבת בהם הכיפה והנשאר
לה עד סוף החדש צריכים לה
לרוץ אורח אחר החמה ואותיות
אלפא ביתא כשהם עם השם
נחשבות אחד אחד עד שאפי׳
ת׳ עם י׳ שבשם שוין י״א ולא
יותר. וזה כי אותיות השם הם
נשמה ואותיות התורה הם כלי
אומנות וכל כלי אין מונים לו
אלא אחד ובדבר הזה אין הבדל
בין מחט אחד למסר הגדול.
ובזה יובן חזרת הענפים אל
מקורן. עוד יש מחלקים שם מ״ב
לשבעה חלקים וכל אחד ממנו
שש אותיות וצירפו אליהם שם
יה״ו אל כל אות יעלו ד׳ פעמים
מ״ב והם קס״ח אותיות. וחלוקם
לששה אותיות יעלו כ״ח מחנות
הלבנה סימנם כח מעשיו הגיד
וכתיב גדול אדונינו ורב כח.
ובהם נפעלים כל הגזרות והם
המחדשים אור חדש במזלות

then it is a legion unto itself.[1]

All the letters of the alphabet were the instruments of the Great Name in the work of Creation. And Yod with kamatz together with Alef occurs six times with six vowel points, and likewise all the other letters of the Name; their total number together is 1,080, which are the divisions and moments of an hour. Besides this, there are 1,080 in the letters of the Name alone without the assistance of the vowel points. Thus, the two aspects of 1,080 and the 12 Divine Names equal 12 times 1,080 for the 12 hours of the day. And if you place the letters of the Name first and Alef at the end, and vice versa, for the 12 hours, the letters with the doubles total 27, corresponding to the 27 complete days in which the moon circles the dome, and what remains until the end of the month is needed for it to run its course after the sun. When the letters of the alphabet are with the Name, they are counted one by one, so that even Tav with Yod of the Name equals 11 and no more. This is because the letters of the Name are the soul, and the letters of the Torah are the instruments of craftsmanship, and every instrument is counted only as one, and in this matter there is no difference between a needle and a large saw. Through this, the return of the branches to their source will be understood.

Furthermore, some divide the 42-letter Name into seven parts, each containing six letters, and by joining the name YHV to each letter, they amount to 4 times 42, which is 168 letters.[2] When divided into groups of six letters, they yield 28 stations of the moon, symbolized by "He has declared the power of His works" (Psalms 111:6), and it is written "Great is our Lord and abundant in power" (Psalms 147:5). Through these are effected all the decrees, and they are what renew fresh light in the zodiacal signs, and according to the renewal of the light, so are renewed the generations of the soul.

[1] This uses biblical allusions (Proverbs 17:2: "A wise servant will rule over a disgraceful son") to explain the mystical properties of the Hebrew vowel point sheva, which despite its normally subordinate status can sometimes take precedence over more prominent vowels.

[2] The 42-letter divine name is one of the most powerful mystical formulas in Kabbalah, often recited in the prayer Ana B'koach. The text describes an advanced mystical calculation system that expands this name through combinations with the divine name YHV to create an even more potent spiritual formula.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic teaching that the Hebrew letters were the instruments through which God created the world, as elaborated in Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), one of the earliest kabbalistic texts.

וכפי התחדשות האור כן יתחדשו תולדות הנפש. וכתב הרמב״ן בפי׳ משנה ד׳ מפ״ג של ספר יצירה כי בעלי חיים הנולדים בשנה זו אינם דומים לבעלי חיים של שנה אחרת.[i] ע״כ אמרו אין מעשרין משנה על של חברתה ע״כ. ובודאי שכן יהיה ג״כ בצמחים ובמתכות ובכל הנבראים. וא״צ לומר במין האדם וכבר דברתי מזה בסוף מעירי שחר במספיק. עוד נ״ל שנוכל ליחס ד׳ שבועי החדש לד׳ הנהגות אבי״ע וכן ד׳ תקופות היום. והנהגת העשיה נרמז אחר חצות שעתא דפתחא דנוקבא רבא סתום פן יחריבו הקליפות העולם ח״ו[ii] כדאמרי׳ בזהר תרומה בטעם שרוח דרום שולט בתחלת הלילה. ולפי זה נייחס ג״כ ד׳ תקופות השנה לד׳ הנהגות אבי״ע פוק חזי כי יעלו הדברים על נכון אחר ההתבוננות בזה. וכן יוחלקו גם י״ב הוי״ות. והראב״ד בפי׳ משנה שניה מספר יצירה העמיק לדבר בדרוש זה בדרך אחרת על פי התכונה והקבלה ובסוף כתב וכאשר תסתכל בחשבון שרמזתי

Nachmanides wrote in his commentary on the fourth mishnah of the third chapter of Sefer Yetzirah that animals born in one year are not similar to animals born in another year. Therefore, they said one may not tithe from one year for another.[1] Certainly, this will also be the case with plants, metals, and all created things, and it goes without saying for the human species. I have already discussed this sufficiently at the end of "Me'irei Shachar." 70R 75R

It further seems to me that we can attribute the four weeks of the month to the four modes of governance of ABYA (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah),[A2] and likewise the four seasons of the day. The governance of Asiyah is alluded to after midnight, when "the gate of the great feminine is closed[B] lest the husks destroy the world, God forbid," as we find in the Zohar Terumah, explaining why the southern wind dominates at the beginning of the night. According to this, we can also attribute the four seasons of the year to the four modes of governance of ABYA—go and see, for these matters will be properly established after contemplating this. And the 12 Divine Names will also be divided in this way. 80R 85R 90R

Raavad, in his commentary on the second mishnah of Sefer Yetzirah, delved deeply into this subject in a different manner based on astronomy and Kabbalah, and concluded: "When you contemplate the calculation I have alluded to, you will be able to 95R

[A] Or: "the four worlds of Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah" — While the original translation correctly identifies the acronym, this alternate translation explicitly clarifies that these are the four cosmic worlds in kabbalistic cosmology, which might be helpful for readers less familiar with the technical term ABYA.

[B] Or: "the time when the gateway of the great feminine principle is sealed" — This alternate translation better conveys the technical kabbalistic terminology where 'nukba' refers to the feminine principle or aspect of divinity, rather than simply 'feminine' which might be misunderstood in a mundane sense.

[1] The author connects a practical halakhic ruling (the prohibition against using animals from one year to fulfill tithing obligations for another year) with mystical concepts about cosmic cycles influencing the essential nature of all created beings.

[2] This refers to the four spiritual worlds in kabbalistic cosmology: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action), which represent increasingly materialized levels of divine manifestation. The author suggests that each week of the month is influenced by a different spiritual world.

[i] The author cites Nachmanides (Ramban, 1194-1270), one of the most influential medieval Jewish scholars, who wrote a commentary on Sefer Yetzirah. The citation supports the kabbalistic concept that cosmic time cycles influence the qualities of all created beings.

[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic belief that after midnight, certain cosmic 'gates' close to protect the world from destructive spiritual forces (kelipot). This concept appears in the Zohar and became important in determining optimal times for mystical practices and prayers.

לך תוכל להבחין ממנו בכל רגע
ובכל שעה ובכל יום שתרצה
ההויה המושלת מי״ב הויות או
משם של כ״ח הויות. ובזה היו
מתגלים לראשונים העתידות
על פי סוד ה׳ בלי שיצטרכו
למלאכת החוזים בככבים
המכזבים.[i] והנה על פי דרכנו
להיות כי רוחניות הי״ב הוי״ות
אותם שהם רחמים יותר שולטים
בשש שעות ראשונות מהיום ולכן
אז ימין ה׳ רוממה וימין ה׳ עושה
חיל להתאזר ולהתגבר נגד מדת
הדין ואז הוא עת לבקש מטו על
צד החסד וגם כי יזכיר עונותיו
אין מקום למדת הדין לחלוק.
ואין לבריא וכ״ש לחולה לשלב
האצבעות של ימין בשל שמאל
כי הם כחות עליונים ימיניים
ושמאליים ואין לערבם.[ii] האמנם
טוב להסתכל ולכוין בכל שעה
באצבעות כי כל אצבע הוא
סוד שם אהיה במלוי יודין
בגמטריא אצבע.[iii] ולהיות דרוש
זה מאד מכוון להשלים אדם
עצמו ולהשתתף עם בחינת האור
המושל מדי עת בעת בתפלותיו
ומעשיו ותורתו ויחודיו וראוי
לכוין למדה וההויה שהיא
שולטת בזמנה לפי חלוף העתים
כמו שאמרו בסדר תפלות
לשחרית מנחה ערבית ומלבד זה
יכוין לספירה השולטת באותו
יום בכלל. לכן יצאנו מעט
מכונת הספר והנה נתבאר כי
טוב לחולה להתודות בשש שעות

discern from it at every moment, hour, and day you wish, which Divine Name is ruling from among the 12 Names or from the 28 Names." Through this, the ancients could discern future events through the secret of God without needing the work of the stargazers who lie. 100R

According to our approach, since the spirituality of the 12 Divine Names—those that are more merciful—dominates in the first six hours of the day, "the right hand of the Lord is exalted, the right hand of the Lord does valiantly" (Psalms 118:16) to gird itself and prevail against the attribute of judgment. This is the time to seek mercy through the aspect of Chesed, and even if one mentions one's sins, there is no place for the attribute of judgment to dispute. A healthy person, and certainly a sick one, should not intertwine the fingers of the right hand with those of the left, for they are supernal powers of the right and left, and they should not be mixed. However, it is good to look at and focus intention on the fingers at all times, for each finger represents the secret of the name Ehyeh filled with Yods, which in gematria equals the word "finger." 105R 110R 115R

This exposition is very much directed toward perfecting oneself and participating with the aspect of light that rules from time to time in one's prayers, deeds, Torah study, and unifications. It is proper to direct one's intention to the attribute and Divine Name that rules in its time according to the changes of times, as they said regarding the order of prayers for morning, afternoon, and evening. Beyond this, one should focus on the sefirah that generally rules on that particular day. Therefore, we have deviated somewhat from the book's purpose, and now it has been explained that it is good for the sick to confess during the first six hours of the day.[1] Now we will 120R 125R 130R

[1] This practical instruction for when confession (vidui) should be performed for the ill connects the preceding mystical discussion to the book's central purpose of providing guidance for caring

[i] The author distinguishes between authentic Jewish mystical methods of divination based on divine names and what he considers false astrological practices. This reflects a common tension in Jewish mystical texts between accepting certain forms of cosmological influence while rejecting non-Jewish divinatory practices.

[ii] This instruction against intertwining the fingers of right and left hands reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the right side represents mercy (chesed) while the left represents judgment (din). For the sick especially, maintaining the dominance of mercy without mixing in judgment was considered essential for healing.

[iii] This is a reference to a specific kabbalistic technique where the divine name Ehyeh (אהיה) is spelled with additional Yods (a practice called 'filling' or 'milui'). When spelled this way (אלף הי יוד הי), its numerical value equals that of the Hebrew word for 'finger' (אצבע = 163).

ראשונות מהיום. ועתה נביא ראיה לזה מספר הזהר מלבד הנדרש: [i]

bring proof for this from the Zohar, beyond what has already been expounded.

פרק ט״ו

Chapter 15

בפרשת בלק דף ר״ד אמר בשעתא דאתי צפרא כל אינון אסירי מלכא אשתכחו נייחין ועידן צלותא איהו עלייהו שכן אינון דתייבין בתיובתא ובעאן בעותהון קמי מלכא קדישא וכו׳ ואח״כ אמר בעא קב״ה זכותיה דההוא בר נש אי אשתכח בצלותא יאות ואי לא חשיב ליה דאיהו מאריה דתיובתא וחס עליה. בההיא שעתא קל צפרין דמקננן אשתמעו. הנה כי אם נגזר עליו חיים ורפואה. הרופא לכל בשר דלית אסוותא ביד שום ממנא אלא בידיה הוא ירפאהו ויעצימהו ואם ג״כ כבר נגזרה עליו גזרה בכח עת שליטת הויות החסד[ii] ימחו

In the portion of Balak, page 204, it states: "At the time when morning comes, all those prisoners of the King are found at rest, and it is a time of prayer for them, especially for those who return in repentance and make their requests before the Holy King, etc." 5R And later it says: "The Holy One, blessed be He, seeks the merit of that person. If he is found in prayer, it is good; and if not, He considers him as one who is a master of repentance and has mercy upon him. At that time, the sound of nesting birds 10R is heard."[1]

Behold, if life and healing have been decreed for him, the Healer of all flesh—for healing is not in the hand of any appointed official but in His hand alone—He will heal him and strengthen him. And if 15R a decree has already been issued against him, then through the power of the time when the Divine Names of Mercy rule, his sins will be erased,[2] as it

for the sick and dying. The text argues that morning hours, dominated by divine mercy, are most favorable for confession.

[2]This Zoharic passage has multiple layers of meaning. Beyond its literal interpretation, it suggests that the chirping of birds at dawn represents both a favorable omen and actual spiritual assistance from the souls of the righteous who pray for the sick person.

[1]The author is explaining that even if a negative decree has already been issued against a sick

[i]Cf. Zohar, Terumah — This reference supports the author's explanation of cosmic time cycles and the shifting dominance of different spiritual forces throughout the day. The Zohar is cited as an authoritative source on the mystical significance of specific times. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — This citation strengthens the author's argument about cosmic cycles influencing all created beings. The reference to Sefer Yetzirah, one of the oldest kabbalistic texts, provides ancient authority for the concept of celestial influences affecting physical reality. | Cf. Raavad (Rabbi Abraham ben David) commentary on Sefer Yetzirah — This reference establishes a lineage of kabbalistic interpretation about divine names and their temporal governance. The author uses Raavad's work to support his own explanation of time cycles while acknowledging alternative approaches within the mystical tradition. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — This is likely a reference to another work by the same author or a prayer collection he compiled. It suggests this current text is part of a larger body of writings on similar mystical subjects, showing the interconnectedness of the author's works. | Cf. Psalms 118:16 — This biblical reference provides scriptural authority for the concept that morning hours are dominated by the attribute of Chesed (divine mercy). The verse's mention of God's 'right hand' connects directly to kabbalistic teachings about the right side representing mercy and kindness. | Cf. 42-letter Divine Name — This section connects to numerous other kabbalistic texts that discuss this important mystical name. This Name was considered one of the most powerful tools for meditation and prayer in Jewish mysticism, used particularly for spiritual ascent and transformation.

[i]This refers to the kabbalistic teaching that different hours of the day are governed by different divine attributes. Morning hours are considered to be under the influence of the divine attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness), making this time especially favorable for divine mercy and forgiveness.

עונותיו כדאמר ואי לא חשיב
ליה דאיהו מארי דתיובתא
וחס עליה. ורמז הצפרים
דקאמר[i] מלבד שיש לדרוש בהם
דברים נעלמים בסוד שכינה
דמקננת במטטרו״ן דאתקריאת
קן צפור ופעמים נשר ופעמים
יונה ע״ד הפשט נוכל להבינם
עם מ״ש הזהר בדף קצ״ו ע״ב
על פסוק גם צפור מצאה בית
אלין רוחיהון דצדיקיא דאמר
כי יש הרבה נשמות המתראים
על ג׳ חומות שבגן עדן כל אחד
כמראה צפרים המצפצפים בכל
בקר והוא צפצופא שבחא
דקב״ה וצלותא על חיי בני נשא
דהאי עלמא ובפרט ביומי ניסן
ותשרי דישראל מתעסקי במצות
ובמע״ט והם מדרגת נשמות
הדרות בחצרים. ועוד יש לפנים
מהם בבתי גוואי. עיין בפ׳
חיי שרה על פסוק אשרי תבחר
ותקרב וגו׳ ובפ׳ מקץ אמר דכל
גרדיני נמוסין מסתלקי בצפרא
וכל חד עאל לדוכתיה כד״א
הבקר אור והאנשים שולחו אלין
מאריהון דדינא המה וחמוריהם
אינון דאתו מסטרא דמסאבא.
כתוב בזהר פ׳ מקץ דף קצ״ח
מאן דלא ישגח בחוביה דחיל
מאינון ימי רע דיצה״ר והזהיר
על עונות דאדם דש בעקביו ע״ד
למה אירא בימי רע וגו׳. ונמצא
כי הוגד טעם למה עונות נעשות
בזכיות למי ששב מאהבה[ii] והוא
כי חובא דחב ב״נ יתיב קמי
קב״ה ואוליף עליה חובא ואמר
פלוני עבד לי ביום פלן. וכד תב

says: "and if not, He considers him as one who is a master of repentance and has mercy upon him." 20R

The reference to birds that is mentioned, beyond the hidden matters that can be expounded about them concerning the secret of the Divine Presence that nests in Metatron, which is sometimes called "bird's nest," sometimes "eagle," and sometimes "dove"—according to the simple interpretation, we can understand them together with what the Zohar writes on page 196b on the verse "Even the sparrow has found a home." These are the souls of the righteous, for it says that there are many souls that appear on the three walls of the Garden of Eden, each like the appearance of birds chirping every morning,[1] and that chirping is praise to the Holy One, blessed be He, and prayer for the lives of people in this world, especially in the months of Nisan and Tishrei when Israel is engaged in commandments and good deeds. These are the level of souls that dwell in the courtyards. And there are yet others deeper within, in the inner chambers. See the section of Chayei Sarah on the verse "Happy is the one whom You choose and bring near," etc., and in the section of Miketz it says that all the enforcers of the law depart in the morning, and each one enters its place, as it is written: "The morning was light, and the men were sent away"—these are the masters of judgment, and "their donkeys" are those that come from the side of impurity. 25R 30R 35R 40R 45R

It is written in the Zohar, portion of Miketz, page 198: "One who does not pay attention to his sin fears those evil days of the evil inclination," and it warns about sins that a person tramples with his heels, as it is written: "Why should I fear in days of evil," etc. And we find that a reason has been given why sins are transformed into merits for one who repents out of love: Because the sin that a person commits sits before the Holy One, blessed be He, and teaches 50R 55R

person, the power of morning prayers during the time when divine mercy dominates can still overturn the decree. This reinforces the book's emphasis on proper timing for deathbed confession.
[2]This passage reveals a profound mystical ecology where the souls of the righteous manifest as birds on the walls of the Garden of Eden, offering prayers for the living. This creates a reciprocal relationship between the living and the dead that is central to Ma'avar Yabok's theology.

[ii]The author engages in multiple levels of interpretation regarding the birds mentioned in the Zohar, offering both mystical and more straightforward readings. The birds simultaneously represent the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), the angel Metatron, and the souls of the righteous.
[i]This references the Talmudic teaching (Yoma 86b) that repentance motivated by love (rather than fear) transforms sins into merits. The author provides a kabbalistic explanation for this profound transformation.

מההוא חובא הא איהו בגרמיה מכריז קמי קב״ה ואמר פלוני דעבד יתי ביום פלן תב בתיובתא מני. אשתכח דחוביה גופיה אוליף עליה זכו והיינו כי נרצה עונה דעון גופיה מרצה קמי קב״ה עליה כי לקאה וגו׳ וע״ד קב״ה יהיב ליה כפלים והקב״ה מוותר חובין לבר נש. ומאי דאמרו כל האומר הקב״ה ותרן יותרון מעוהי[i] ה״מ כדלא תייבין אבל תייבין ומתחרטין ותוהין על הראשונות קב״ה שביק לון ויהיב לון אגר טב.[ii]

accusation against him, saying, "So-and-so did me on such-and-such a day." And when he repents of that sin, behold, he himself proclaims before the Holy One, blessed be He, saying, "So-and-so who did me on such-and-such a day has repented of me." Thus it is found that his sin itself teaches merit for him, and this is the meaning of "her iniquity has been pardoned," for the sin itself appeases the Holy One, blessed be He, on his behalf because it has been smitten, etc. And therefore, the Holy One, blessed be He, gives him double,[1] and the Holy One, blessed be He, forgives sins for a person. And what they said, "Whoever says the Holy One, blessed be He, is a forgoing—may his intestines be foregone," applies only when they do not repent, but when they repent and regret and are remorseful for their past deeds, the Holy One, blessed be He, forgives them and gives them a good reward.

ויקיים כל אדם ובפרט בעל תשובה וכ״ש החולה בחליו פסוק שויתי ה׳ לנגדי תמיד והוא בצייר תמיד במחשבתו שם ההוי״ה כתוב בכתב אשורית בדיו שחור בס״ת כשר[iii] ובכן ירא ויחרד מלפניו ומחשבותיו

Every person, especially one who has repented, and all the more so a sick person in their illness, should fulfill the verse "I have set the LORD always before me"[A] (Psalms 16:8). This is accomplished by constantly visualizing in one's mind the Divine Name (YHVH) written in Assyrian script with black ink, as in a valid Torah scroll. In this way, one will fear

[A] Or: "I place the LORD before me constantly" — This alternate translation emphasizes the active, ongoing nature of the practice rather than just a past action.

[1] This refers to the concept that through proper repentance, not only are sins forgiven, but they are transformed into merits, effectively doubling the spiritual benefit. This reinforces the book's emphasis on deathbed confession as spiritually beneficial rather than merely obligatory.

[ii] This is a reference to a statement in the Jerusalem Talmud (Bava Kamma 9:4) warning against the view that God simply forgives without requiring repentance. The author is carefully distinguishing between improper reliance on divine forgiveness without repentance versus the genuine transformation that occurs through sincere repentance.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Balak 204 — The Zohar text is used to establish morning as an optimal time for confession (vidui), since at dawn divine mercy predominates over judgment, making it more favorable for repentance to be accepted. | Cf. Zohar, 196b on 'Even the sparrow has found a home' — This reference connects the chirping birds mentioned in the primary text to the souls of the righteous, suggesting that when a sick person hears birds at dawn, it may represent righteous souls praying for them and offering divine protection. | Cf. Zohar, Miketz 198 — This Zoharic teaching explains the profound metaphysical mechanics of repentance, where the sin itself becomes an advocate rather than an accuser, supporting Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper confession before death. | Cf. Talmudic saying 'Whoever says the Holy One, blessed be He, is forgoing—may his intestines be foregone' — The author uses this Talmudic saying to contrast with his teaching, emphasizing that while God is not arbitrarily forgiving of unrepented sins, sincere repentance does indeed transform divine judgment into mercy.

[i] This describes a meditation technique where one visualizes the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) as it would appear in a kosher Torah scroll, written in the formal Assyrian script with black ink. This practice derives from Psalm 16:8 and became a central contemplative method in Jewish pietistic literature.

יכונו ע״כ מצאתי כתוב ודברים
אלו טוב שהמודה לחולה
יזכירם לו אם הוא ת״ח המבין
דבריו ויאמרם אליו קודם
שיתודה להלהיב לבו לתשובה
באמור אליו שיחשוב לתקן
פרטי העבירות אשר פגם בהם
בחייו כנזכר למעלה ואם היא
אשה תכוין לתקן בודויה פגמה
בשמירת פתחי נדותה ומצות
חלה והדלקת הנר[i] ובביטול
תורה שגרמה לבעלה או לבניה
אם נתעצלה להוליכם לבית
הספר.[ii] ה״ה נמי לשאר פריצות
אחר. וכן אם נתעצלה בהדלקת
נר שבת ולא הוסיפה מחול על
הקדש כי תוספת זה הכנה לנפש
יתירה מעולם האצילות[iv] [iii]

and tremble before Him, and one's thoughts will be properly directed. So I have found written, and it is good for the one guiding the sick person's confession to remind them of these things if they are a Torah scholar who understands such matters. He should say these things before the confession to inspire their heart to repentance, telling them to consider rectifying the particular transgressions they damaged through during their lifetime, as mentioned above. If the sick person is a woman, she should intend through her confession to rectify damage to her observance of the laws of menstrual purity, the commandment of separating challah, and the lighting of candles, as well as any neglect of Torah study she may have caused her husband or children if she was lazy about bringing them to school.[1] The same applies to other immodest behaviors. Similarly, if she was negligent in lighting Sabbath candles and did not add from the secular to the sacred,[2] for this addition prepares for the additional soul from the world of Atzilut (Emanation).[A]

[A] Or: "the extra soul from the realm of Atzilut" — This alternate translation might be more accessible to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology, while still preserving the essential meaning.

[1] The text reveals a gendered division of religious responsibilities in traditional Judaism, where women were expected to ensure their sons received proper religious education, even if they themselves were exempt from formal Torah study obligations.

[2] This refers to the practice of tosefet Shabbat—extending the Sabbath by beginning it earlier than required and ending it later. This extension was considered spiritually meritorious and is here connected to receiving the 'additional soul' that Jews traditionally believe descends on the Sabbath.

[ii] These are the three primary religious obligations specifically incumbent upon women in rabbinic Judaism: niddah (menstrual purity laws), separating challah (from dough), and lighting Sabbath/holiday candles. According to rabbinic tradition, women's careful observance of these commandments has special protective power for their households.

[iii] This reflects the traditional view that while women were generally exempt from formal Torah study obligations, they bore responsibility for ensuring their sons' education and for not interfering with their husbands' study time. A woman's spiritual accounting thus included how she facilitated others' Torah study.

[iv] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of neshamah yeteirah (additional soul) that descends upon Jews during Sabbath. According to this teaching, adding time to the Sabbath by beginning it early creates a spiritual vessel for receiving this additional soul from Atzilut, the highest of the four spiritual worlds in Lurianic Kabbalah.

[v] Cf. Zohar — The passage alludes to Zoharic teachings about the neshamah yeteirah (additional soul) that descends upon Jews during Sabbath from the world of Atzilut. The text connects Sabbath candle-lighting with creating a spiritual vessel to receive this additional soul. | Cf. Ethical literature — The instruction to visualize the Divine Name reflects practices found in medieval Jewish ethical literature, where visualization of God's name was recommended as a method to maintain constant awareness of divine presence and prevent sin. | Cf. Maimonides — The differentiated approach to confession based on gender and specific life circumstances parallels Maimonides' approach to repentance, which emphasizes specificity in acknowledging particular sins rather than general confessions.

וצריך להוסיף ממדרגת החול
שהחצונים אוחזים בו לעשותו
קדש לקדשו בקדושת שבת
ונסתמו המקורות לחול ונפתחו
לשבת להזריע פנימה סוד
הנשמות הקדושות ולהפסיק
מהטיפין החצונים שהיו סוד מים
עכורים מותר המעשה שנשארו
שמרי מעשה בראשית והיו
נמשכים והולכים. וזהו אמרם
שהמזיקים נבראו ערב שבת בין
השמשות וכשראה הקב״ה כך
הקדים קדושת שבת[i] ונתייחדה
שכינה אל הזכר והזריע פנימה
כנזכר כי מזיקין אלו היו נצוצות
נזרקים מלמעלה[ii] קודם היות
השכינה פנים אל פנים עם הזכר
והדרוש רחב במקומו אצלנו.
וצריך שמירה והכנה לקבל כח
הרוחני כי הוא משפיע תמיד
והגשמים מקבלים ממנו כפי
הכנתם ובשבת בפרט כתיב
ושמרו בני ישראל את השבת
מלשון ואביו שמר[iii] ובזה עושים
ומתקנים אותו לדור אתם
והדלקת נר שבת ע״י עקרת הבית
אחר זרוז בעלה היא תקון גדול

One must add from the level of the mundane in which the external forces have a hold, to transform it into holiness by sanctifying it with the sanctity of the Sabbath.[1] Thus, the channels for the mundane are sealed, and those for the Sabbath are opened, to inseminate internally the mystery of the holy souls and to halt the external drops, which were the secret of the turbid waters, the remnant of creation,[A] which were the dregs of the work of creation that continued to flow. This is the meaning of the sages' statement that harmful spirits were created on the eve of the Sabbath at twilight, but when the Holy One, blessed be He, saw this, He advanced the sanctity of the Sabbath, and the Divine Presence united with the masculine aspect and inseminated internally, as mentioned. For these harmful spirits were sparks thrown from above before the Divine Presence was face to face with the masculine aspect, and this topic is extensively discussed in its place in our work.[B]

105R 110R 115R 120R

Protection and preparation are necessary to receive spiritual power,[2] for it is constantly emanating, and physical beings receive from it according to their preparation. Particularly regarding the Sabbath, it is written, "The children of Israel shall keep the Sabbath," using the same term as "his father kept the matter," and through this, they create and establish it to dwell with them. The lighting of the

125R

[A] Or: "the mystery of turbid waters, the excess material from the act of creation" — The kabbalistic concept of 'waters' here refers to spiritual energies or forces. 'Motar ha-ma'aseh' specifically refers to the leftover or excess energies from the creation process. This alternate translation better captures the technical kabbalistic meaning.

[B] Or: "and we have elaborated on this subject elsewhere in our work" — This idiomatic phrase indicates that the author has discussed this topic more extensively elsewhere. The alternate translation conveys this meaning more naturally in English while maintaining the author's intent to reference his more detailed treatment of the subject elsewhere.

[1] This kabbalistic concept describes the spiritual transformation of mundane reality (chol) into sacred time (kodesh) that occurs with the onset of Sabbath. According to the mystical understanding presented here, this is not merely a change in time designation but an actual metaphysical transformation of reality.

[2] The text presents a cosmology where spiritual forces constantly emanate from above, but their reception depends on proper preparation below. This reflects the kabbalistic principle of 'awakening from below' (itaruta d'letata) that triggers 'awakening from above' (itaruta d'leila).

[i] This refers to the rabbinic teaching that harmful spirits were created on the sixth day but weren't completed because God sanctified the Sabbath before their creation could be finished. This is used to explain why these spirits are particularly active at twilight on Friday.

[ii] In Lurianic Kabbalah, these 'sparks thrown from above' refer to divine sparks that fell during the cosmic 'Breaking of the Vessels' (Shevirat ha-Kelim). These scattered sparks became the source of negative spiritual forces when not properly contained.

[i] This quotes Genesis 37:11 regarding Jacob 'keeping' or 'guarding' Joseph's dream, suggesting that 'keeping' the Sabbath similarly involves active watchfulness rather than mere passive observance.

להכנת קדושת שבת עם תקון
מט״ה ש״לחן כ״סא ו״מנורה[i] היא
הנר ונקודה אמצעית קדושת
שבת שוכן בכסא דהיינו בריאה
וגבולה אלפים אמה סביב עולם
היצירה נכלל במטטרו״ן ששם
יה״וה משתמש בו הוא בחינת
אלף אמה סביב ואלף אמות
אחרים סביב הם רמז לעולם
העשיה סנדלפון ששם אדנ״י
משתמש בו א׳ סוד הנהגת היום
בחול וא׳ סוד הנהגת הלילה
ולזה אין לחלל נקודה אמצעית
קדושת שבת מתחומה ובתוס׳
שבת נמצא מקדש מדרגות החול
ג״כ. ואמרו בתקונים שהמוסיף
להוציא בסעודת שבת מוסיפין
לו נפש יתירה שהיא תוספת
רוח הקדש וכל הפוחת להוציא
גורעין לו ההוא נפש יתרה
ונשאר עני. ובדף פ״ח ע״א אמר
כי צריך בשבת כלה לטעום
מכל המאכלים ולקיים בו ענג.
וכבר מפורש סוד ענג אצלנו
במקום אחר וללבוש בגדים
נאים. וכתבו גורי האר״י שכפי
גוון המלבושים שאדם לובש
בשבת בעה״ז כך ממש יתלבש
אחר פטירתו בימי שבת תמיד.
ושלכך נראה חכם אחד לבוש
שחורים אחר פטירתו בימי
שבת והגיד כי כך לבש בעה״ז
ונענש במדה ההיא בעצמה. עוד
אמרו בזהר כי האושפיזין הם
המלאכים נערי הנשמה יתירה
דאיהי שבינתא וצוה רשב״י
בפרשת ויקהל כי תתפלל האשה
בעת הדלקתה נר של שבת על

Sabbath candle by the mistress of the house, after her husband's encouragement, is a great rectification for preparing the sanctity of the Sabbath, together with the preparation of the bed, table, chair, and lamp[1] (which is the candle). The central point of Sabbath sanctity dwells in the "chair," meaning the world of Beriah, whose boundary is two thousand cubits surrounding the world of Yetzirah, which is encompassed by Metatron, where the divine name YHVH operates through him. This is the aspect of one thousand cubits surrounding,[2] and the other thousand cubits surrounding symbolize the world of Asiyah, where Sandalphon serves as the vehicle for the divine name Adonai—one representing the mystery of daytime governance on weekdays, and the other the mystery of nighttime governance. Therefore, one must not profane the central point of Sabbath sanctity beyond its domain, and through the addition to the Sabbath, the levels of the mundane are also sanctified.

It is said in the Tikkunim that one who increases expenditure for the Sabbath meal receives an additional soul, which is an increase of the holy spirit, while one who reduces expenditure loses that additional soul and remains impoverished. On folio 88a, it states that on the Sabbath, which is like a bride, one should taste from all the foods and fulfill the obligation of delight. The mystery of "delight" is already explained elsewhere in our work, as is the obligation to wear fine garments. The disciples of the Ari wrote that according to the color of the garments a person wears on the Sabbath in this world, so will they literally be clothed after their death on Sabbath days forever. And therefore one sage was seen dressed in black after his death on Sabbath days, and he declared that this was how he dressed in this world and was punished in that very measure.[A]

Furthermore, it is stated in the Zohar that the

[A] Or: "And for this reason, a certain sage appeared after his death wearing black garments on

[1] These four items (מטה שלחן כסא ומנורה) correspond to the furnishings provided for the prophet Elisha by the Shunammite woman (2 Kings 4:10). In kabbalistic tradition, they represent the four fundamental preparations for the Sabbath, each with its own spiritual significance.

[2] The text presents a complex cosmological model where physical measurements correspond to spiritual boundaries between different worlds. The 'thousand cubits' measurement relates to the Sabbath boundary (techum Shabbat) but is given mystical significance as the demarcation between cosmic realms.

[i] These are the four items Elisha's Shunammite hostess provided for him (2 Kings 4:10), which in kabbalistic tradition represent the four fundamentals of a properly prepared Sabbath home.

חיי בעלה ובניה שיזכו לתורה
אור. ובפרשת תרומה דף קס״ז
זירז לצורך תיקון גבוה שהאיש
יעסוק בתורה לאור נר של
165 שבת כי נשי בההוא עלמא זכיין
בבנייהו ובבעלייהו וכבר נשאל
מר׳ אליעזר לרשב״י נשי בההוא
עלמא מה אינון והעלה אותן
הרבה. והמבין מה שאמרו על
170 פסוק אני ישנה שהמלכות אומר
אני שניה לחכמה[i] בסוד דו
[ii] פרצופין שהיו בה ובבינה

celestial guests are the angels who attend the additional soul, which is the Divine Presence. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai instructed in Parashat Vayakhel 170R
that a woman should pray at the time of lighting the Sabbath candle for the life of her husband and her sons, that they may merit the light of Torah. And in Parashat Terumah, folio 167, he urged for the sake of higher rectification that a man should en- 175R
gage in Torah study by the light of the Sabbath candle, for women in that world merit [reward] through their sons and husbands. Rabbi Eliezer already asked Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai about women's status in that world,[1] and he elevated them considerably. One 180R
who understands what they said about the verse "I was asleep" [knows] that the attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom) says, "I am second to Wisdom," in the mystery of the dual aspects that were in her and in Binah[2] (Understanding). 185R

נתגלו בסוד ו״ד בדמות חותם

They were revealed in the secret of vav-dalet[3] in the

Sabbath days, and he revealed that this was how he had dressed on the Sabbath in this world and was now punished in exactly the same manner" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the cause-and-effect relationship between the sage's actions in life and his condition after death, specifically highlighting that his punishment corresponded precisely to his failure to honor the Sabbath with appropriate clothing.

[1]This refers to a discussion in the Zohar about whether women have independent spiritual merit in the World to Come or if their reward comes primarily through their role in enabling their male relatives' Torah study. The author notes that Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's answer elevated women's spiritual status.

[2]This refers to the complex kabbalistic concept of 'du-partzufin' (dual countenances or aspects), where divine attributes contain masculine and feminine elements within themselves. This passage specifically relates to how Malkhut (Kingdom) and Binah (Understanding) share this dual nature, creating a mystical connection between these different sefirot (divine emanations).

[3]This refers to Kabbalistic letter symbolism. The Hebrew letters vav (ו) and dalet (ד) represent masculine and feminine principles respectively in mystical teachings.

[i]This interpretation relates to the kabbalistic concept that Malkhut (Kingdom, the lowest sefirah) describes herself as 'second to Wisdom' (Chokhmah, the second highest sefirah), establishing a mystical connection between these seemingly distant divine attributes.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Terumah — The author uses this Zoharic reference to establish the spiritual importance of the Sabbath candles and their connection to Torah study, strengthening his argument about proper Sabbath observance having consequences in both this world and the next. | Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel — This reference emphasizes the spiritual power of the moment of candle lighting and the special role women play in bringing spiritual illumination to their families through this ritual act. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:2, 'I was asleep, but my heart was awake' — This mystical interpretation of Song of Songs presents Malkhut (the Shekhinah or Divine Presence) as the feminine aspect of divinity, which parallels the human feminine role in sanctifying the Sabbath through candle lighting. | Cf. Writings of the Arizal — This reference to Lurianic Kabbalah establishes the mystical principle that physical actions in this world create corresponding spiritual realities in the next world, specifically regarding how one's Sabbath garments in life determine one's spiritual 'clothing' after death. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This reference establishes the spiritual economy of Sabbath observance, where physical generosity in this world results in spiritual abundance in the form of an enhanced soul experience.

המתהפך ועוד עליית ת״ת
ומלכות עד הכתר יבין סוד
ברכת הנשים בבקר שמברכות
שעשאני כר״צונו ואין לך כשרה
בנשים אלא העושה רצון בעלה
וצנועה בירכתי ביתה. וטבע
האשה היא הכנה גדולה למזג
בניה אם לטוב אם למוטב יותר
הרבה מהאיש ולכן ימכור אדם
כל מה שיש לו וישא אשה הגונה
וממשפחה כשרה כי כל טוב
אדוניה בידיה. ותחלת קלקול
הבנים ח״ו יצמח מהפקר האשה
כי עקר הצניעות תלוי בנקבה
וע״י כך יהיו הבנים צנועים.
וגם הבעל ע״י יהיה צנוע. וזהו
תחלת הקלקול בדור המבול כי
בנות יולדו להם דכשההולדה
רעה מתאוה גשמית יחוסה
לעצמה לא להקב״ה. ולילית
יש לה מבא להלביש בחותיה
הטמאות באשה פרוצה וע״י
הפריצות הנהוג בעת הזיווג
וכמו שאין שום נברא ונוצר
ונעשה מרגיש בזווג העליון כן
זווג תחתון לא יהיה בגלוי ח״ו.
עוד פריצות הדור הווה בשהזכר
או הנקבה נותנים המחשבה
באחר שלכן נקראים בני תמורה.
וכמו שהאשה ביום יוצאה פרועת
הראש בשוק ופרומה או שאר
מיני פריצות כדאמרי׳ בכתובות
למקום ההוא נדחית נפשה
בלילה בכחות ההפקר וכמה
רעה אשה רעה רחמנא לישזבן
כי מטמא׳ ברית העליון ושפחה
תירש גברתה וכן האיש אם אינו
שומר בריתו כראוי גורם פריצות
לאשתו כדאמרי׳ פ״ק דסוטה

form of a reversing seal, and furthermore, the ascent of Tiferet and Malkhut to Keter[1] explains the mystery of women's morning blessing, where they bless "who has made me according to His will." And there is no virtuous woman except one who fulfills her husband's will and is modest in the recesses of her home. A woman's nature is a greater influence on her children's temperament, whether for good or bad, much more than the man's influence. Therefore, a man should sell all he has to marry a suitable woman from a worthy family, for all her master's goods are in her hands.[2] The beginning of children's corruption, God forbid, stems from a woman's lack of restraint, because the essence of modesty depends on the female, and through this, the children will be modest. The husband too will become modest through her. This was the beginning of corruption in the generation of the flood, when "daughters were born to them,"[3] for when procreation stems from physical desire, its lineage is attributed to itself, not to the Holy One, blessed be He. Lilith has an entry point to clothe her impure forces in an immodest woman through the immodesty practiced during marital relations. Just as no created being senses the supernal union, so too the earthly union should not be exposed, God forbid. Another immodesty of the present generation occurs when either the male or female directs their thoughts to another during intimacy, which is why such children are called "children of substitution." Just as a woman who goes out in public with uncovered hair, unbuttoned clothing, or other forms of immodesty (as mentioned in Tractate Ketubot), her soul is pushed at night into forces of lawlessness. How evil is an evil woman—may the Merciful One save us—for she defiles the supernal covenant, and "a maidservant inherits her mistress."[4] Similarly, if a man does not properly guard his covenant, he causes immodesty in his wife, as we say in the first chapter of Sotah: Rabbi Yochanan said, "Anyone who is

190R 195R 200R 205R 210R 215R 220R 225R

[1]These are three of the ten divine emanations (sefirot) in Kabbalah. Tiferet represents masculine divine energy, Malkhut represents feminine divine energy, and Keter is the highest divine emanation, representing God's crown or supreme will.

[2]This alludes to Proverbs 31:11, describing the 'woman of valor' whose husband trusts in her management of the household.

[3]This quotes Genesis 6:1, referring to events preceding the flood when 'the sons of God saw the daughters of men that they were fair.'

[4]This quotes Proverbs 30:23, which lists 'a handmaid that is heir to her mistress' among four things that disturb the earth. In this mystical context, it suggests that lower spiritual forces (Lilith) usurp the place of higher ones (the Shekhinah).

אר״י כל המזנה אשתו מזנה עליו וכו׳ וסיים איהו בי קרי ואיהי בי בוציני. ואם פגמה מעשיה ובפרט בדברים המיוחדים אליה תעלם על לבה בהיותה על ערש דוי בקלקול שגרמה לה ולבעלה ובפרט לבניה והכל יזכור לה החכם המודה אותה אם מדבר על אוזן שומעת: [i]

promiscuous—his wife will be promiscuous against him," concluding "he [experiences] nocturnal emissions, and she [frequents] places of oil lamps [where illicit meetings occur]." If she has damaged her deeds, especially in matters particular to her, she should recall in her heart when she is on her sickbed the corruption she caused to herself, her husband, and especially her children. The wise person who guides her confession[1] should remind her of all this if he speaks to a receptive ear. 230R 235R

פרק ט״ז

Chapter 16

מה שחדשנו בנוסח הוידוי [ii] אלהי ואלהי אבותי בו׳ המובא לעיל בסדרר הוידוי [iii] [iv]

Regarding what we have innovated[2] in the wording of the confession[3] "My God and God of my fathers, etc." that was presented above in the order of confession

ויכוין החולה כי נכלל בודויו זה ג׳ ודוים נגד חטא עון

The sick person should intend that his confession includes three confessions corresponding to sin, in- 5R

[1] This refers back to the broader context of Ma'avar Yabok as a guide for deathbed practices, where a religious guide would help the dying person through proper confession (vidui). This passage specifically addresses what women should confess regarding their particular religious obligations.
[2] The author uses the first-person plural ('we have innovated') which is a common rhetorical style in rabbinic writing, often called the 'royal we' or 'authorial we.' It doesn't necessarily indicate multiple authors.
[3] This indicates that the author has made modifications to the traditional deathbed confession text, a significant liturgical innovation that would require explanation and justification.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The passage is steeped in Kabbalistic cosmology, particularly the Zoharic understanding of human sexuality as a reflection of divine unions between Tiferet (masculine) and Malkhut (feminine). The warnings about immodesty are based on the belief that human actions affect cosmic harmonies. | Cf. Genesis 6:1-2 — The author interprets the biblical story of the flood as being caused by sexual impropriety, suggesting that the daughters mentioned in Genesis 6 were born from improper desires rather than sacred intentions. | Cf. Tractate Ketubot — The author draws on rabbinic teachings about modest behavior for women to support his mystical understanding of how immodesty affects the soul and cosmic harmony. | Cf. Tractate Sotah — The quote is used to establish a principle of measure-for-measure punishment, where a man's sexual impropriety leads to his wife's unfaithfulness, reinforcing the kabbalistic idea that human behavior has corresponding effects in both physical and spiritual realms. | Cf. Proverbs 30:23 — This biblical verse is reinterpreted kabbalistically to suggest that improper behavior allows lower spiritual forces (the "maidservant" Lilith) to usurp the place of higher ones (the "mistress" Shekhinah).
[ii] The word 'vidui' (confession) refers specifically to the ritual confession prayer recited before death. This is a central practice in Jewish end-of-life ritual, designed to facilitate spiritual reconciliation and the soul's peaceful transition.
[iii] There is a typographical error in the original text with the word 'סדרר' (seder), which should be 'סדר' (order). This refers to the structured sequence of the confession prayer presented earlier in Ma'avar Yabok.
[iv] Cf. Vidui (confession) — The author is referring to modifications he made to the standard deathbed confession text that was presented earlier in the book. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is a self-reference to an earlier section of the book where the author presented the full text of the confession prayer that is now being discussed.

ופשע[i] ולתקון אלפא ביתא רבתי בינונית וזעירא את מהם בבינה והשנית בת״ת והשלישית במלכות ולתקון ת״ת ומלכות ויסוד הנפגמים בחטא עון ופשע והוא כלל ופרט וכלל חטאתי עויתי פשעתי הוא כלל בג׳ מיני עבירות הפוגמים כנזכר ואח״כ מפרט באלפא ביתא ואח״כ כולל במלות סרתי ממצותיך וממשפטיך הטובים שהם בחינות ת״ת ויסוד ומלכות. וכבר כתבנו בכונת הודוי בהקדמתינו למעירי שחר. לבד זה נוסיף הכא כאשר הורנו הגאון מפאנו בדרושי ספר העסיס שלו כי באמרו מה נאמר לפניך עד סוף הודוי יכוין ליחד בעל הרצון המרומם מכל ברכה ותהלה נשמת כל הנשמות עלת כל העלות ברצון העליון. והרצון ברעותין שהם המחשבות הנעלמות ואולי זה יהיה בחינת מלכין קדמאין[ii] שהם בחכמת הכתר כנתבאר בספר אלימה.[iii] והרעותין בנהורין שהם סוד התקונים שהם בכתר בינת הכתר דאינון אור קדמון צא ומצוחצח ונהורין. והם הדוגמא העליונה לאור החוזר ממטה למעלה להשגת הרעותין

iquity, and transgression, and to rectify the large, medium, and small alphabets—one of them in Binah, the second in Tiferet, and the third in Malkhut—and to repair Tiferet, Malkhut, and Yesod, which are damaged by sin, iniquity, and transgression. This follows the pattern of general-specific-general:[1] "I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled" is the general statement covering the three types of transgressions that cause damage as mentioned. Then he specifies through the alphabetical confession, and afterward includes everything in the words "I have turned away from Your commandments and Your good judgments," which represent the aspects of Tiferet, Yesod, and Malkhut.

We have already written about the intention of confession in our introduction to Me'irei Shachar. Beyond this, we will add here what the Gaon of Fano[2] taught us in his discourses in his book Ha'asis: when reciting "What can we say before You" until the end of the confession, one should intend to unify the Master of Will—who is exalted beyond all blessing and praise, the Soul of all souls, the Cause of all causes[A]—with the Supreme Will. And the Will with the Desires, which are the hidden thoughts—perhaps this refers to the Primordial Kings who exist in the Wisdom of Keter,[B] as explained in the book Elimah. And the Desires with the Lights, which are the secret of the Rectifications that exist in Keter, the Understanding of Keter, which are the Primordial Light, Pure and Radiant, and the Lights. These are the supreme model for the

[A] Or: "the Master of Will who is elevated above all blessing and praise, the Soul of all souls, the Prime Cause of all causes" — This alternate translation preserves the meaning while using slightly different theological terminology that might be more familiar to some readers.

[B] Or: "perhaps this corresponds to the Primordial Kings that are in the Wisdom aspect of Keter" — This alternate translation more precisely conveys the relationship between the Primordial Kings and the specific aspect of Keter being referenced.

[1] This refers to the rabbinic hermeneutical principle of 'klal u-prat u-klal' (general-specific-general), which is being applied here to the structure of confession.

[2] This refers to Rabbi Menachem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an Italian kabbalist and Talmudist who was an important transmitter of Lurianic Kabbalah in Italy.

[i] The Hebrew terms חטא (chet), עון (avon), and פשע (pesha) represent a hierarchical taxonomy of transgression in rabbinic literature: chet refers to inadvertent sins, avon to deliberate violations, and pesha to rebellious acts against God.

[ii] The 'Primordial Kings' (מלכין קדמאין) is a kabbalistic concept from Lurianic Kabbalah referring to primordial worlds that existed and were destroyed before the current creation, associated with the concept of 'breaking of the vessels' (shevirat ha-kelim).

[iii] Sefer Elimah is a major kabbalistic work by Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), one of the foremost systematizers of kabbalah before Isaac Luria.

שרש האור ישר ונהורין הם ראשי נקודות נעלמות והם שרשים לכל המאמרות ונהורין מתפשטים לעשר צחצחות הובא נקודת שמותם בתקונים. ובתוך הצחצחות מתפשט אור הספירות והספירות מתלבשים במאמרות הנפש אליהם הוא כלל המאמרות. רוח אליהם הם הספירות המתלבשים במאמרות נשמה הם הנהורין חיה הרעותין יחידה רעותה וכלם נתנו מרועה אחד בעל הרצון. ונוסח מה נאמר מורה התקשרות נשמה בנשמות למבין ומעיין בו. והאור מתפשט בספירות מכתר לתר״ך עמודי אור[i] שבו וכלם נכללים מכל א׳ מהם ומתר״ך עמודי כתר לחכמה ומחכמה לל״ב נתיבותיה[ii] ומשם לבינה ומבינה לחמשים שעריה[iii] וכל א׳ בלול מכלם ומשם לחסד ומחסד לע״ב גשרים[iv] ומשם לגבורה ומגבורה לרי״ו אורותיה[v] ומשם לת״ת ומת״ת לע׳ ענפים[vi] ומשם לנצח עד המלכות. ומשם יורד הרוחניות בכסאות ששם בחינת השרפים ובהם ד׳ דרגין ושית סמכין ומכסאות לחיות שהן שבעה היכלות ומחיות לאופנים.

reflected light ascending from below to attain the Desires, which are the root of the direct light.[A] The Lights are the heads of hidden points, and they are the roots of all utterances, and the Lights extend into the ten Radiances, the points of their names brought in Tikkunim. 40R

Within these Radiances, the light of the Sefirot extends, and the Sefirot clothe themselves in utterances. The Nefesh corresponds to the totality of utterances. The Ruach corresponds to the Sefirot clothed in utterances. The Neshamah corresponds to the Lights. The Chayah corresponds to the Desires. The Yechidah corresponds to the Will. And all of them were given by one Shepherd, the Master of Will. The formula “What can we say” indicates the connection of soul to souls for one who understands and contemplates it. 45R 50R

The light extends through the Sefirot from Keter to the 620 pillars of light[1] within it, all of which are included in each of them. From the 620 pillars of Keter to Chokhmah, and from Chokhmah to its 32 paths, and from there to Binah, and from Binah to its 50 gates, each one including all the others. From there to Chesed, and from Chesed to its 72 bridges, and from there to Gevurah, and from Gevurah to its 216 lights, and from there to Tiferet, and from Tiferet to its 70 branches, and from there to Netzach, all the way to Malkhut. 55R 60R 65R

From there, the spirituality descends into the Thrones, where the aspect of the Seraphim resides,

[A] Or: “for the returning light that ascends from below to apprehend the Desires, which form the root of the direct light” — The term ‘returning light’ (or ‘rebounding light’) might better convey the kabbalistic concept of or chozer than ‘reflected light,’ and ‘apprehend’ might better capture the mystical nature of the relationship between the lights and desires.

[1] The number 620 (תר״ך) equals the numerical value of ‘keter’ (כתר, crown) when spelled out in full, plus the value of the letter itself, representing the complete manifestation of the highest divine emanation.

[i] The Hebrew letters תר״ך (tav, reish, khaf) have the numerical value of 620, referring to the 620 pillars of light said to emanate from the divine crown (Keter).

[ii] The ‘32 paths’ refers to the 32 paths of wisdom described in Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), consisting of the ten sefirot and the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet.

[iii] The ‘50 gates of Binah (Understanding)’ is a kabbalistic concept representing the complete emanation of divine understanding, with tradition holding that Moses achieved 49 of these gates but not the 50th.

[iv] The Hebrew letters ע״ב (ayin, bet) have the numerical value of 72, referring to the 72-letter divine name derived from three verses in Exodus 14:19-21.

[v] The Hebrew letters רי״ו (reish, yod, vav) have the numerical value of 216, which is 3 times 72, possibly referring to the expansion of the 72-letter divine name.

[vi] The Hebrew letter ע׳ (ayin) has the numerical value of 70, representing the 70 branches or aspects of Tiferet, possibly corresponding to the 70 nations or 70 languages in rabbinic tradition.

ומהאופנים למדורים קדושים ומשם לגלגלים ומגלגלים לחומר פשוט גרם החמישי ומשם
70 לארבעה יסודות שמהם הורכבו כל הנבראים תחתונים ברוך שככה לו בעולמו וברא כל אלה לכבודו: [i]

containing four levels and six supports.[1] From the Thrones to the Chayot, which are the seven palaces, and from the Chayot to the Ofanim. From the 70R
Ofanim to the holy dwellings, and from there to the celestial spheres, and from the spheres to the simple matter of the fifth element,[2] and from there to the four elements from which all lower creatures were formed. Blessed is He who has such a universe and 75R
created all these for His glory.

אח״כ יאמר רבון כל כל
75 העולמים[ii] המובא לעיל בסדר הוידוי עד סוף כל הוידוי. [iv iii]

Afterward he shall say "Master of all Worlds" [A] which was presented above in the order of confession[B3] until the end of the entire confession.[4]

[A] Or: "Afterward one should recite 'Sovereign of all the Universes'" — While 'Master of all Worlds' is accurate, 'Sovereign of all the Universes' might better convey the cosmic scope of the divine title. However, since 'Ribono shel Olam' is a standard liturgical formula, the original translation may be more recognizable to readers familiar with Jewish prayer.

[B] Or: "in the vidui liturgy" — Using the transliterated Hebrew term 'vidui' preserves the technical religious meaning that might not be fully captured by 'confession,' which has different connotations in other religious traditions.

[1] This appears to describe the structure of the angelic realm of the Seraphim as having four primary angels corresponding to the four 'camps' of angels described in Jewish mystical tradition, supported by six secondary angelic forces.

[2] In medieval Jewish philosophy and Kabbalah, the 'fifth element' or 'quintessence' (החומר החמישי) refers to the ethereal substance of which celestial bodies were thought to be composed, distinct from the four elements of the sublunary world.

[3] This confirms that Ma'avar Yabok is structured as a practical manual, with prayers presented in full in one section and then referenced when needed in other sections, allowing religious functionaries to navigate efficiently between different ritual scenarios.

[1] This instruction clarifies that even when adapting the confession for specific circumstances, the

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author draws on Zoharic concepts of how human transgressions damage the connections between divine attributes (sefirot), and how proper confession with mystical intention (kavvanah) can repair these connections. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author refers to his own previous work to indicate continuity in his teachings about proper intention during confession, suggesting this is part of a comprehensive system. | Cf. Sefer Ha'asis by Rabbi Menachem Azariah da Fano — The author acknowledges Rabbi Menachem Azariah da Fano as his teacher and source for the detailed kabbalistic system he presents, establishing his intellectual lineage and the authority behind these mystical teachings. | Cf. Sefer Elimah by Rabbi Moses Cordovero — The reference shows the author integrating Cordoverian Kabbalah into his system, particularly regarding the complex structure of the highest sefirah of Keter and its relationship to primordial cosmic structures. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author draws on this text to explain the structure of divine emanation and how human intentions during confession interact with this cosmic structure to create spiritual repair.

[ii] This appears to be a scribal error with the word 'כל' (all) repeated twice. In standard Hebrew it would be written just once as 'רבון כל העולמים'.

[i] This instruction refers to a prayer formula that was presented in full earlier in the text. Such cross-references are common in liturgical manuals like Ma'avar Yabok to avoid repetition of lengthy prayer texts.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This reference confirms that Ma'avar Yabok is structured as a practical manual, with prayers presented in full in one section and then referenced in other sections where they should be recited. | Cf. Ribono shel Olam prayer — The use of this traditional prayer formula places the deathbed confession within the established framework of Jewish penitential prayers, connecting the individual's final moments to the broader tradition of Jewish spiritual practice.

פרק י״ז

Chapter 17

קול אומר בן אדם[i] קרא הקריאה הזאת תמיד[ii iii]

A voice proclaims:[1] “Son of man, recite this reading constantly”[2]

מקומות רבו מספר מצינו בדברי חכמים כי יש לאדם הצדיק לשמוח שמחה רבה ביום מיתתו כי יודע ה׳ ימי תמימים ונחלתם לעולם תהיה ונשמת הצדיק היא מרכבה לשכינה[iv] גם אחר המות כנודע ממדרגת חנוך ואליהו מרכבת האבות. הנה אמרו בכתובות פ׳ הנושא מת מתוך שחוק סימן יפה לו. והנה טוב מאוד זה מות. ובפ׳ תרומה דף קמ״ט רשב״י פי׳ בזה. ואמרו במדרש ובגמרין וירושלמי פ״ג דע״א. בשעת סלוקן של צדיקים הקב״ה מראה להם מתן שכרן ונפשם שבעה והם ישנים. וכתב בעל העקדה בשער כ״ב שראיית מתן שכר ביום המיתה מתחייב מסמיכותו אל קבול השכר כמו

We find numerous instances in the words of our Sages where the righteous person should greatly rejoice on the day of their death,[3] for “the LORD knows the days of the blameless, and their inheritance shall be forever.” The soul of the righteous becomes a chariot for the Divine Presence[A] even after death, as is known from the levels of Enoch and Elijah, and the chariot of the Patriarchs. The Talmud states in Ketubot, chapter “He Who Marries”: “One who dies while laughing—this is a good sign for them.” And “behold, it was very good” refers to death.[4] In Parashat Terumah, page 149, Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai explains this. And they said in the Midrash, Gemara, and Jerusalem Talmud, third chapter of Avodah Zarah: “At the time when the righteous depart, the Holy One, blessed be He, shows them their reward, and their souls are satisfied as they sleep.”

The author of the Akedah wrote in Gate 22 that

[A] Or: “vehicle for the Divine Presence” — While ‘chariot’ is the literal translation of ‘merkavah,’ the modern term ‘vehicle’ might better convey the functional meaning to contemporary readers—that the righteous soul serves as a means for divine manifestation.

complete concluding formula should still be recited in full, maintaining the ritual’s integrity regardless of the circumstances.

[2] This opening formula establishes divine authority for the text that follows, similar to prophetic introductions in biblical literature.

[3] This appears to be a heading for a meditation on mortality that follows in the text, marking it as something to be contemplated regularly as spiritual preparation.

[4] This striking opening sets the tone for the entire passage, establishing the counterintuitive mystical perspective that death—far from being feared—should be celebrated by the righteous as a spiritual promotion.

[1] This is a rabbinic interpretation of Genesis 1:31 that paradoxically identifies death as part of what God declared ‘very good’ in creation, suggesting it has positive spiritual value rather than being merely the result of sin.

[iii] The phrase ‘son of man’ (ben adam) echoes God’s form of address to the prophet Ezekiel throughout his book, creating a prophetic tone for this meditation.

[iv] The instruction to recite ‘constantly’ reflects the Jewish practice of regular meditation on mortality as a spiritual discipline, not out of morbidity but as preparation for a righteous life and death.

[v] Cf. Ezekiel — This opening phrase adopts prophetic language to establish the spiritual gravity of what follows, suggesting that the reading is of divine origin and importance, similar to how God addressed Ezekiel before delivering messages. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok — This line serves as an introduction to a meditation on mortality that follows in Ma’avar Yabok, marking it as something to be recited regularly as spiritual preparation for death.

[vi] The concept of becoming a “chariot for the Divine Presence” (merkavah la-Shekhinah) is a mystical image describing how the righteous soul serves as a vehicle for divine revelation, similar to Ezekiel’s vision of the divine chariot. This status continues even after death.

שזהרורי חמה יראו בעולם קודם
זריחת השמש כן השכר להיותו
מזומן להם לכן יתחייב הראותו
ביום המיתה. והבדרשי כתב
שבסור המסכים הטבעיים אשר
שמם האל בבריאותו מחוברים
לנפשו המונעים אמיתת השגתו
ישיגו בהכרח מה שהיה נעלם
מתחלה. ולפי האמת הוראת
השכר סמוך למיתה אינו אלא
כדי שתפרד בלא צער כדכתב
הרב האלשיך בפי׳ מאמר זה.
וגרסינן בכתובות פרק הנושא
א״ר יוסי בן שאול בשעה שהצדיק
נפטר מן העולם אומרים מלאכי
השרת לפני הקב״ה רבש״ע
צדיק פלוני בא אומר להם יבא
בשלום וצדיקים יוצאים לקראתו
ואומרים לו יבא שלום ינוחו על
משכבותם. עוד שם ג׳ כתות של
מלאכי השרת יוצאות לקראתו
אחת אומרת לו בא בשלום וכו׳.
ואמרי׳ במס׳ שבת על גופן של
צדיקים הוא אומר יבא שלום
ינוחו על משכבותם ועל נשמתן
הוא אומר והיתה נפש אדוני
צרורה וגו׳. וגם נראה גדולת
הצדיקים ביום מיתתן מרבה בר
נחמני שהכריע בין הישיבה של
מעלה ולא היה כדאי הכרעתו
אלא בעת דנח נפשיה שלהיות כי
לא בשמים היא הוצרך ההכרעה
מאחד ממקבלי התורה בעודו
חי ברם היה סמוך למיתה כי אז
תוסף רוחם ומשם נראה שהספד
הוא ז׳ ימים דאז נפל פתקא
מן שמיא לכו לבתיכם לשלום.
כדאי׳ פ׳ השוכר את הפועלים.
ונראה ג״כ טוב הצפון לצדיקים
ממ״ש רבי אבהו ואני אמרתי
לריק יגעתי וריק בגימטרי״א
ש״י והיה אומר כי היה סבור

seeing one's reward at the time of death necessarily follows from its proximity to receiving the reward—just as rays of the sun appear in the world before sunrise, so too the reward, being prepared for them, must be shown on the day of death. And Bedarschi wrote that when the natural veils that God placed in his creation, which are attached to one's soul and prevent true comprehension, are removed,[1] one necessarily perceives what was previously hidden. In truth, the revelation of reward just before death is only so that the soul may depart without distress, as Rabbi Alshikh wrote in his explanation of this statement. 25R 30R

The Talmud states in Ketubot: Rabbi Yosi ben Shaul said, "When a righteous person departs from the world, the ministering angels say before the Holy One, blessed be He, 'Master of the Universe, a certain righteous person is arriving.' He says to them, 'Let him come in peace,' and the righteous go out to greet him and say to him, 'May he come in peace; they shall rest on their beds.'" It also states there that three groups of ministering angels go out to meet him; one says, "Come in peace," etc. And we say in Tractate Shabbat, regarding the bodies of the righteous, it says, "May he come in peace; they shall rest on their beds," and regarding their souls, it says, "The soul of my lord shall be bound in the bond of life," etc. 35R 40R 45R

The greatness of the righteous on the day of their death is also apparent from Rabbah bar Nachmani, who decided between the heavenly academy, and his decision was only worthy when his soul departed. Since "it is not in heaven," the decision had to come from one who had received the Torah while still alive, yet it was close to his death, for then "their spirit increases."[2] From this, it appears that the mourning period is seven days, for then a note fell from heaven: "Go to your homes in peace," as stated in the chapter "One Who Hires Workers." 50R 55R 60R

The goodness stored away for the righteous is also evident from what Rabbi Abbahu said: "And I said, 'I have labored in vain,'" where "vain" (ריק) has the

[2]The text presents a Neoplatonic concept that the physical body and its sensations act as veils that obscure spiritual reality. Death removes these veils, allowing the soul to perceive divine truth directly.

[1]This refers to the Jewish mystical concept that as death approaches, the soul begins to detach from bodily limitations and can access higher spiritual knowledge, explaining why deathbed statements of the righteous are considered especially significant.

להתעדן בי״ש עולמות[i] שעתיד
65 הקב״ה להנחיל לכל צדיק אך
עתה מלבד י״ש עולמות היו
מראים לו עידון תלת עשר נהרי
אפרסמונא דכיא[ii] הנמשכים
מתוך עמודי אור שבמדת הכתר.
70 וי״ש הם בחכמה ושם בחינת
עולם התהו. שאין בו השגה כלל.
והרגיל בשותא דרבנן יבין מהו
ריק ותהו והבל שאמר כאן ר׳
אבהו. גם נראה שכר הצדיקים
75 ממה שאמרו הג׳ צדיקים אחרים
שכל אחד מהם אמר פסוק א׳
בשעת סילוקו ובהרבה מקומות
אחרים בגמרא ובמדרשים:
ובזהר פ׳ ויחי כתוב וצדיקי איתי
80 להו למחדי ביומא דמסתלקי
מן עלמא. וכי לאו יקרא עלאה
איהו דמטרוניתא אתת לאובלא
לון להיכלא למחדי בהו כל
יומא. דקב״ה לא אשתעשע אלא
85 בנשמתהון דצדיקיא ואתערותא
דרחימו דישראל לגבי קב״ה
נשמתהון דצדיקיא לתתא מתערי
לון דאינון אתיין מסטרא דמלכא
מסטרא דדכורא ואתערותא דא
90 מטא לנוקבא מסטרא דדכירא
וכו׳. ולכן יום פטירתם של
צדיקים נקרא הלולא[iii] בדחזינן
בעובדא דר׳ יצחק בפ׳ הנ״ל
כשאביו א״ל שהיו עתידים לצאת
95 לקראתו י״ב צדיקים ושהיה
ג׳ ימים שהיו מתקנים מקום
כבודו באורות עליונים. והאריך
שם להודיעו גודל הכנת מקום

numerical value of 310, and he was saying that he
had thought he would delight in the 310 worlds that 65R
the Holy One, blessed be He, will bequeath to each
righteous person. But now, beyond the 310 worlds,
they were showing him the delight of the thirteen
rivers of pure balsam oil that flow from the pillars of
light in the attribute of Keter. And the 310 are in 70R
Chokhmah, and there is the aspect of the World of
Tohu,[A] which cannot be comprehended at all. One
who is familiar with rabbinical discourse will under-
stand what "vain," "void," and "futility" mean, as
Rabbi Abbahu says here. 75R

The reward of the righteous is also evident from
what the three other righteous individuals said, each
of whom recited a verse at the time of their depar-
ture, and in many other places in the Talmud and
Midrashim. 80R

In the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, it is written:
"The righteous should rejoice on the day they depart
from the world.[B] Is it not a supreme honor that the
Matronita (Divine Presence) comes to escort them to
the palace to rejoice with them every day? For the 85R
Holy One, blessed be He, delights only in the souls of
the righteous, and the arousal of Israel's love toward
the Holy One, blessed be He, is through the souls
of the righteous below, who arouse them, for they
come from the side of the King, from the masculine 90R
side, and this arousal reaches the feminine from the
masculine side," etc.

Therefore, the day of the righteous' departure is
called a hillula (wedding celebration), as we see in
the story of Rabbi Yitzchak in the aforementioned 95R
passage, when his father told him that twelve right-
eous individuals were prepared to go out to greet
him, and that for three days they had been prepar-

[A] Or: "World of Formlessness" — While 'Tohu' is the standard transliteration, 'Formlessness' better conveys the meaning of this kabbalistic concept to readers unfamiliar with Hebrew terminology, referring to the primordial state before differentiation.

[B] Or: "And the righteous have reason to rejoice on the day they depart from the world" — This translation more clearly conveys that the original Aramaic 'איתי להו' implies 'they have' or 'there is for them' a reason or cause for rejoicing, not merely that they should rejoice as a commandment.

[i] The numerical value of י״ש (310) represents the 310 worlds that each righteous person will inherit in the World to Come, a concept found in rabbinic literature. The text elevates this reward by adding the "thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil."

[ii] These "rivers of pure balsam oil" are a mystical Zoharic image for celestial channels of divine pleasure reserved for the righteous in the afterlife. They represent a higher form of spiritual delight than the 310 worlds mentioned earlier.

[iii] The term "hillula" (wedding celebration) is used in Kabbalistic literature to refer to the death anniversary of great sages, particularly Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai. This reframes death as a joyous spiritual union rather than a sorrowful separation.

רשב״י בעולם ההוא יעויין
100 משם ובסוף אמר לו דבהלולא
רבא דר׳ שמעון בן יוחאי תהא
מתקן פתוריה. הנה כי מיתת
הצדיקים היא חופה עליונה
שלהם. ואמר רשב״י בתחלת
105 אדרת האזינו[i] כי צוה שיביאו לו
רבי יצחק שהיה ערב לו להביאו
עמו אמר לרבי אלעזר בנו אימא
לרבי יצחק דיסדר מלוהי ויתיב
לגבאי זכאה חולקיה. וכמה
110 פעמים אמר. זכאה חולקי יומא
דין. הנה כי יום שמחה וחדוה
לצדיקים ועל זה נאמר יקר
בעיני ה׳ המותה לחסידיו: ועיין
מדרש רבה בפרשה ט׳ על פסוק
115 והנה טוב מאד שהפליג לדבר
בטוביות יום המות ובטוביות
היסורין. וכן אמרו בפרק ואלו
מגלחין כי הקב״ה חומד נפשות
ושמח בהן בכלה חדשה. רוכב
120 ערבות[ii] שהוא מקום שבו תתעדן
הנשמה כדמשמע מתוך דברי
ההקפות שיסדרו לפנינו בחג
הוא שש ושמח בבא אליו נפש נקי
צדיק. וכן אמר שלמה בחכמתו
125 וחוסה במותו צדיק. ואפי׳
לפי דברי הפלוסוף יוכרח
טוביות יום המות שהם חלקו
המאמרות באמרם שהם חלקי
המציאות לעצם ומקרה. וחלקו
130 המקרה לתשע קראו אותם עשרה
מאמרות. מאמר ראשון הוא
העצם. מאמר שני נקרא מאמר
האנה. והשלישי מאמר המצב.
והרביעי מאמר שיפעל וכו׳
135 ואין לנו להאריך בדברים שבדו

ing his place of honor with supernal lights. He elaborated there to inform him of the greatness of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's place in that world (see there), and in the end, he said to him, "At the great hillula of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, you shall prepare his table." Thus, the death of the righteous is their supernal wedding canopy. 100R 105R

Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai said at the beginning of the Idra Ha'azinu that he commanded them to bring Rabbi Yitzchak, who had guaranteed to bring him along. He said to his son Rabbi Elazar, "Tell Rabbi Yitzchak to arrange his affairs and sit with me; fortunate is his portion." And he said many times, "Fortunate is my portion on this day." Thus, it is a day of joy and gladness for the righteous, and of this it is said, "Precious in the eyes of the LORD is the death of His pious ones." 110R 115R

See also Midrash Rabbah, Parashah 9, on the verse "And behold, it was very good," which elaborates on the goodness of the day of death and the goodness of sufferings. Similarly, they said in the chapter "And These Shave" that the Holy One, blessed be He, desires souls and rejoices in them like a new bride. The Rider of Aravot,[1] which is the place where the soul delights, as implied in the words of the Hakafot (Circlings) that they will arrange before us on the festival, rejoices when the pure soul of a righteous person comes to Him. And so Solomon said in his wisdom, "And He spares the righteous at their death." 120R 125R

Even according to the philosopher,[2] the goodness of the day of death must be acknowledged, for they divided the statements in their saying that they are parts of existence into substance and accident. And they divided accident into nine, calling them the ten statements. The first statement is substance. The second statement is called the statement of "where." 130R 135R

[1] This divine title from Psalm 68:5 refers to God as transcending the highest heaven. The text uses this image to depict God joyfully receiving the souls of the righteous, similar to a bridegroom receiving his bride.

[1] The text incorporates Aristotelian philosophical categories (the ten statements or categories) to argue that even from a philosophical perspective, death represents the completion of human purpose rather than its negation.

[ii] This refers to the "Idra Ha'azinu" (Assembly of Ha'azinu), a mystical gathering of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his disciples recorded in the Zohar, where profound kabbalistic teachings were revealed. It is named after the Torah portion "Ha'azinu".

[iii] This is a divine title meaning "Rider of the Highest Heaven" (based on Psalm 68:5), referring to God as dwelling in the highest celestial realm called Aravot, where righteous souls experience divine delight after death.

מלבם רק נשכיל שהם אמרו במאמר האנה שהוא ראשית כל התנועות בהתחלתן וכל תנועה תורה על חסרון המתנועע כמו שהמנוחה מורה על שלימותו והגעת תכליתו הנה האדם במותו שהוא נח מהרגשותיו מורה על כי הגיע לתכליתו. ולהלהיב לב הקוראים להיות תמיד בה׳ מבטחם ובפרט ביום המיתה בחרתי להציע פה מה שהוגד לאלוף הדור מהר״רי קאר״ו וג״כ שהחכם גלא״נטי בפירוש איכה הנקרא קול בוכים רמז מנו קצת בכל מקום בפרטותו יתבאר כתר גדולת הצדיקים בעולם העליון וכה הוגד אליו: [i]

The third is the statement of "position." The fourth is the statement of "action," etc. We need not elaborate on things they invented, but we should understand that they said in the statement of "where" that it is the beginning of all movements in their commencement, and every movement indicates a deficiency in the one moving, just as rest indicates completeness and the attainment of one's purpose. Thus, a person at death, who rests from their sensations, indicates that they have reached their purpose.

To inflame the hearts of readers to always place their trust in the LORD, especially on the day of death, I have chosen to present here what was told to the leader of the generation, Rabbi Joseph Karo, and also what the sage Galanti alluded to in his commentary on Lamentations called "Kol Bochim." In each place, the details will be explained regarding the crown of greatness that the righteous possess in the supernal world, and thus it was told to him:

פרק י״ח

Chapter 18

אחר שבליל שבת שלשים לאדר שנת שי״ן [ii] נאמרלו כי ידבק בה׳ ותמיד יסדר המשניות ובזה יגדיל השם שבחו בכמות ואיכות כאשר היה באמת נאמר לו ובתר

After the Sabbath night of the thirtieth of Adar in the year 310 [1550 CE], it was told to him: "Cleave to the Lord and always arrange the Mishnayot,[1] and through this the Name will magnify His praise in quantity and quality." As was indeed told to him:

[1] This refers to the practice of regularly studying the Mishnah, the first major written collection of Jewish oral traditions. The text suggests that this specific spiritual practice leads to divine favor.

[i] Cf. Ketubot 103b — This Talmudic source is cited to support the idea that death for the righteous is not a tragedy but rather a joyous transition, as evidenced by the positive interpretation of dying with a smile. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah 149b — The Zohar provides a mystical interpretation of Genesis 1:31, suggesting that death itself is part of the divine good of creation, particularly for the righteous who transition to spiritual reward. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Avodah Zarah, Chapter 3 — This reference supports the concept that righteous souls experience divine revelation and preview their spiritual reward at the moment of death, making it a desirable transition rather than a fearful one. | Cf. Sefer HaAkedah (by Rabbi Isaac Arama), Gate 22 — This philosophical source provides a rational explanation for the mystical concept of seeing one's reward before death, framing it as a natural preview of what is about to be fully experienced. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — This Zoharic passage provides the mystical basis for the concept of 'hillula' (celebration) associated with the death of righteous individuals, depicting it as a divine escort and spiritual wedding rather than a sorrowful event. | Cf. Bava Metzia 86a — This reference illustrates how the moment of death can be a time of spiritual elevation and clarity for the righteous, when they can access divine wisdom and even resolve heavenly disputes. | Cf. Psalms 116:15 — This biblical verse is cited as the fundamental scriptural basis for the entire discussion, establishing that God values and treasures the death of the righteous rather than viewing it as a tragedy. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah on Genesis 9 — This midrashic source develops the paradoxical concept that death is part of what God declared 'very good' in creation, suggesting it has positive spiritual value rather than being merely the result of sin.

[i] The Hebrew year 310 (shin) corresponds to 1550 CE. The use of the letter shin (numerical value 300) plus yod (10) indicates a date in the Jewish calendar.

כל דין אזכך לאתוקדא על
קדושת שמי[i] שזהו יום מיתתו
בנזכר. וכל חובך ועוייתך
ישתארון בנורא. ותסתלק
מתמן כעמר נקי. ויפקון כל
צדיקיא דבגנתא דעדן לקראתך
ויקבלון יתך בכמה שיראן וכמה
תושבחן וידברוך קדמיהון כחתן
דמהלך בראש וכולהון מלוין
יתך עד דתמטי לחופה דילך
והא. אזדמנו לך שבעה חופות
זו לפנים מזו ושבעה חופות
אחרנין זו למעלה מזו[ii] ובחופה
פנימאה ועילאה שבע נהרן
דאפרסמונא[iii] ותמן מתקנן לך
כורסייא דדהבא בשבע דרגין
וקביעין בה כמא מרגלאן ואבנין
דיקר דלית להו טימי ולעילא
מן כורסייא תליא כתרא דדהבא
וקביעין בה מרגלאן ואבנין
דיקר והא כל צדיקיא ילוון יתך
וישוררו קמך עד דתמטי לחופה
קדמאה ותמן ילבשון יתך לבושי
דיקר. וכן בכל חופה וחופה עד
שביעאה ובתר יעלון יתך לחופי

"And after all this, I will purify you to be consumed for the sanctification of My Name"[A]—this refers to the day of his death, as mentioned. "And all your sins and iniquities will remain in the fire.[B] And you will ascend from there like pure wool.[C] And all the 10R
righteous ones in the Garden of Eden will come out to meet you and receive you with many songs and praises, and they will lead you before them like a groom who walks at the head,[1] and all of them will accompany you until you reach your wedding canopy. 15R
Behold, seven canopies are prepared for you, one inside the other, and seven other canopies, one above the other. And in the innermost and highest canopy are seven rivers of pure balsam oil,[2] and there a golden throne is prepared for you with seven levels,[3] set with numerous pearls and precious stones that have no price. And above the throne hangs a golden crown, set with pearls and precious stones. And all the righteous will accompany you and sing before you until you reach the first canopy, and there 25R
they will dress you in precious garments. And so in each canopy until the seventh. And afterward they will bring you up to the higher canopies and dress you in precious garments, until when you enter the final canopy, you will have fourteen precious garments 30R

[A] Or: "And after all this, I will refine you to be burnt as an offering for the sanctification of My Name" — The Aramaic term "לאתוקדא" literally refers to burning, and in mystical contexts often alludes to a spiritual refinement through fire. This alternate translation emphasizes the sacrificial metaphor implied in the original text.

[B] Or: "And all your debts and transgressions will be left behind in the fire" — The Aramaic terms "חובך" and "עוייתך" can be rendered more specifically as "debts" and "transgressions," highlighting the concept of spiritual accounting in kabbalistic thought.

[C] Or: "And you will depart from there like cleansed wool" — The Aramaic "תסתלק" could also be translated as "depart" rather than "ascend," and the wool metaphor refers to the whitening process of purification, which might be better captured by "cleansed" rather than simply "pure."

[2] This comparison to a groom reflects the mystical concept of death as a form of marriage between the soul and the divine, a reunion with its source that is celebrated rather than mourned.

[3] In rabbinic literature, these rivers represent the highest form of spiritual pleasure reserved for the righteous. The number seven signifies completeness or perfection in Jewish tradition.

[4] The seven levels of the throne likely correspond to the seven lower sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah, representing the soul's mastery of all spiritual attributes.

[ii] This phrase uses language reminiscent of martyrdom ("kiddush hashem"—sanctification of God's name), suggesting that the righteous death described is viewed as a sacred sacrifice.

[iii] The text describes a total of fourteen canopies arranged in two sets of seven—seven nested within each other and seven stacked vertically. This complex spatial arrangement reflects kabbalistic cosmology with its multiple nested worlds and hierarchical spiritual levels.

[iv] "Rivers of pure balsam oil" (naharei afarsimon) appear frequently in Talmudic and kabbalistic literature as a reward for the righteous in the afterlife. These are not physical rivers but spiritual channels of divine pleasure and wisdom.

עילאי וילבשון יתך לבושין דיקר
עד דכד תעייל בחופה בתראה
ישתכחו עליך י״ד לבושי דיקר
ויקומון תרי צדיקים מאינון
דמלוין יתך ויקומון חד לימינך
וחד לשמאלך בשושבינא לחתן
ויסקון יתך לבושא לכורסיא.
ובעידן דתשרי למיסק ילבשון
לבוש דיקר על י״ד לבושין
דעלך בכוונא דישתכחו עלך
ט״ו לבושין דיקר ובהא יותיבו
יתך בכורסייא. ויסבון כתרא
דתליא ויחתון יתה ברישך ותתיב
על בורסי מלכותא והני תרין
צדיקים דהוו לך שושבינין
יתיבון חד מימינך וחד משמאלך
וכל אינון צדיקייא יתיבון
סחור סחור שקלו וטרו עמך
במילי דאורייתא[i] אלין נפקין
ושאר כל צדיקייא עאלין ושקלי
וטרו עמך במילי דאורייתא
וכן עד דישלם מאה ושמנים
יומין דוגמא בהראותו את עושר
כבוד מלכותו וגו׳ ובתר כן
תעביד לכל צדיקייא דבגנתא
דעדי משתייא דאורייתא[ii] שבעת
יומין דוגמא ובמלאת הימים
וגו׳ שבעת ימים בחצר גינת
ביתן המלך[iii] דהיינו גנתא
דעדן דאיהו דוגמת שושן בחצר

upon you.[1] And two righteous ones from among those accompanying you will stand, one at your right and one at your left, like attendants for a groom, and they will bring you clothed to the throne. And at the time when you begin to ascend, they will dress you in 35R a precious garment over the fourteen garments that are upon you, with the intention that there will be fifteen precious garments upon you,[2] and with this they will seat you on the throne. And they will take the hanging crown and place it on your head, and 40R you will sit on the royal throne. And these two righteous ones who were your attendants will sit, one on your right and one on your left, and all those righteous ones will sit around in a circle and discuss matters of Torah with you.[A] These will leave, and 45R other righteous ones will enter and discuss matters of Torah with you, and so on until one hundred and eighty days are completed,[3] corresponding to 'when he showed the riches of his glorious kingdom' [Esther 1:4]. And afterward, you will make for all the righ- 50R teous in the Garden of Eden a feast of Torah for seven days, corresponding to 'and when these days were completed' [Esther 1:5]—'seven days in the court of the garden of the king's palace' [Esther 1:5], which is the Garden of Eden, which is like Shushan, in the 55R court of the garden of the king's palace. Because they are many, the court of the garden of the king's palace is needed. And throughout these seven days, you alone will expound on matters of Torah that you learned in this world and that they taught you during 60R

[A] Or: "and engage in dialectical Torah discourse with you" — The Aramaic expression "שקלו וטרו" is a technical term referring specifically to the back-and-forth dialectical reasoning of Talmudic discourse, which could be more precisely captured in this translation.

[1] In kabbalistic numerology, fourteen is twice seven, representing completeness in both spiritual and material realms. These garments symbolize spiritual accomplishments that clothe the soul.
[2] The number fifteen in Jewish mysticism represents the divine name Yah (יה), with numerical values of 10 and 5. This final garment elevates the soul to a higher level of divine connection.
[3] This specific timeframe, drawn from the Book of Esther, may symbolize a complete cycle of spiritual elevation. In gematria (Jewish numerology), 180 equals the Hebrew word "פנים" (face), possibly suggesting a direct face-to-face encounter with the divine.

[i] The Aramaic expression "shaklu ve-taru" is a technical term from Talmudic discourse referring to the give-and-take of dialectical reasoning. Its use here suggests that heavenly Torah study involves the same intellectual engagement as scholarly study on earth.
[ii] The phrase "feast of Torah" (mishtaya d'oraita) portrays Torah study as a form of spiritual sustenance and celebration, suggesting that advanced mystical knowledge is consumed and enjoyed like a royal banquet.
[i] The text draws directly from Esther 1:5, using the Persian royal garden as a metaphor for the Garden of Eden. This represents the Jewish mystical tradition of finding deeper spiritual meanings in biblical narratives.

גינת ביתן המלך משום דסגיאין
אינון אצטריך חצר גינת ביתן
המלך וכל תוך שבעה יומין
תדרוש אנת בלחודך במלין
דאורייתא דאוליפת בהאי עלמא
ודאוליפתך בהון ק״פ יומין
ובתר כן יקומון כל צדיקיא
דבגנתא דעדן וידברון יתך
קדמיהון כחתן וכולהון מלוין
יתך ומדברין בתרך וקצתהון
אדברין קמך ומכרזי קמך
ואמרו פנו מקום לברא תמימא
קדישא דמלכא עלאה[i] והבו יקר
לדיוקנא דמלכא קדישא וכולהו
מזמרין ומשבחין עד דמטו עמך
לאתר די״ג נהרי אפרסמונא ואת
טביל בקדמאה והכי מתעדי מינך
חד לבושא מאינון דאת לביש וכן
בתנייתא וכן בכולהו עד דכד את
טבילה בי״ג הא אעדיאו מינך י״ג
לבושין. ובתר כן הא נהר דינור
נגיד ונפיק[ii] ותטבול ביה ויתעדי
מינך לבושא י״ד וכד תסתלק
מינך לבושא דא הא מזמנין
לבושין דיקר חיוורין[iii] ואלבשון
יתך והא כהנא רבא זמין לאסקא
נשמתך קמי קוב״ה ומכאן ואילך
ליית רשו לגלאה דעין לא ראתה
אלהים זולתך יעשה למחכה
לו. הא רזין אלין שדרני מלכא

those one hundred and eighty days. And afterward, all the righteous in the Garden of Eden will rise and lead you before them like a groom, and all of them will accompany you and guide you after them, and some will lead before you and announce before you, saying: 'Make way for the perfect holy son of the Supernal King, and give honor to the image of the Holy King.' And all of them will sing praises until they arrive with you at the place of the thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil.[1] And you will immerse in the first, and thus one garment of those you are wearing will be removed from you, and so in the second, and so in all of them, until when you immerse in the thirteenth, thirteen garments will have been removed from you. And afterward, behold, the River of Fire flows forth,[2] and you will immerse in it, and the fourteenth garment will be removed from you. And when this garment is removed from you, behold, white precious garments are prepared, and they will clothe you. And behold, the High Priest is ready to bring your soul before the Holy One,[3] blessed be He. And from here onward, there is no permission to reveal, for 'Eye has not seen, O God, besides You, what He has prepared for those who wait for Him'[4] [Isaiah 64:3]. Behold, these mysteries the Holy King and His entire academy have sent me [to tell you]."

65R 70R 75R 80R 85R

[1] The number thirteen in Jewish tradition corresponds to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy and represents divine compassion. Each immersion removes one garment, suggesting the stripping away of limited identity to reveal the soul's essence.

[2] This final immersion in the River of Fire represents the ultimate purification that prepares the soul for its highest possible elevation. In mystical texts, this river serves as a boundary between lower and higher spiritual realms.

[3] This likely refers to the archangel Michael, who is often portrayed in Jewish mystical literature as the heavenly High Priest who offers the souls of the righteous as sacrifices before God.

[4] This quotation from Isaiah 64:3 serves as both a scriptural validation of the vision and an acknowledgment of its limitations, suggesting that even this elaborate description falls short of the actual divine rewards that await the righteous.

[i] The soul is described as the "perfect holy son of the Supernal King," reflecting the kabbalistic concept that human souls are divine sparks or children of God returning to their source.

[ii] The "River of Fire" (nehar dinur) appears in the Book of Daniel (7:10) and features prominently in Jewish mystical literature as a purifying force through which souls and even angels must pass. It represents the ultimate spiritual purification.

[iii] The white garments represent the final state of spiritual purity after all traces of worldly existence have been removed. In kabbalistic thought, white garments symbolize the soul's restored primordial purity.

[i] קדישא וכל מתיבתא דיליה

לאודעותך בגין דתחזיק גרמך בהאי דרגא ולא תבא לידי חטא אפי׳ בהרהור. עוד נאמר לו פעם אחרת דמתיבתא דיליה לקבל מתיבתא עילאה[ii] והוסיף להודיעו שכל ישיבה שלומדים למטה יש דוגמתה למעלה בשמים. ובזה נראה ג״כ מבואר בדרושי דר׳ אילא בזהר שלח. כמה רזין אית לאפקא ממלין אלין בסוד לבושים ראשונים ושניים וחופות הצדיקים[iii] ושושבינין דלהון וכתר השמור להם בעולם הנשמות וטבילתם להחזק עוד נשמתם שתהיה להכח וחיל לקבל שכרה השמור לה לפנים מהפרגוד כי רב הוא. עוד

...to inform you so that you maintain yourself at this spiritual level[A] and not come to sin even in thought. He was further told that his academy corresponds to the supernal academy,[1] and he was informed that for every academy of learning below, there exists a corresponding one above in heaven. This is also clearly explained in the discourses of Rabbi Ila in the Zohar, Parashat Shelach. How many mysteries can be derived from these matters concerning the secret of the first and second garments, the canopies of the righteous, their attendants, and the crown reserved for them in the World of Souls![2] Their immersion strengthens their souls further, empowering them to receive their reward which is kept for them beyond the celestial curtain,[3] for it is immense. 90R 95R 100R

I further found that when Rav Chisda departed to his eternal home,[4] his son Rav Yosef went and

[A] Or: "...to make known to you so that you strengthen yourself in this level" — This more literal translation captures the Aramaic expression's emphasis on self-strengthening (גרמך—'yourself') and the active nature of maintaining one's spiritual level. It might be preferable when a more direct rendering of the original idiom is desired.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic principle of correspondence between earthly and heavenly realms, where human institutions and practices have divine counterparts in the spiritual worlds.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic realm where souls reside after death, one of several spiritual domains that souls traverse in their posthumous journey.

[1] The 'celestial curtain' (פרגוד) is a mystical concept similar to a veil that separates different spiritual realms. In rabbinic literature, it represents the barrier between divine knowledge and human comprehension.

[2] The text uses the euphemistic expression 'went to his eternal home' (הלך לבית עולמו) to refer to death, reflecting the Jewish tradition of using gentle language when discussing mortality.

[i] Cf. Book of Esther — This reference establishes a correspondence between earthly royal ceremonies and heavenly rewards, suggesting that the celestial experience of the righteous exceeds even the most lavish earthly celebrations described in scripture. | Cf. Zohar — This visionary account draws directly from Zoharic traditions about the soul's ascent through various heavenly realms after death, where the righteous soul is greeted by spiritual companions, adorned with celestial garments, and participates in heavenly Torah study. | Cf. Midrash on Proverbs 31:25 — The fourteen and fifteen garments mentioned represent layers of spiritual achievement and divine protection, with each garment symbolizing different aspects of spiritual accomplishment that the soul carries into the afterlife. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 17a — This text elaborates on the talmudic vision, providing a more detailed and sequential account of how souls transition into that exalted state through multiple stages of purification and elevation. | Cf. Isaiah 64:3 — This biblical quote serves as both a textual boundary (marking where the revelation ends) and a meditation prompt, suggesting that the described experiences are merely a glimpse of even greater divine rewards that cannot be fully articulated.

[ii] This expresses the kabbalistic concept of correspondence between earthly and heavenly academies, following the principle 'as above, so below.' The phrase uses Aramaic terminology common in the Zohar.

[iii] These terms refer to the spiritual garments and canopies that souls receive in the afterlife, with the 'first garments' typically referring to those acquired through Torah study and good deeds, while 'second garments' are additional layers of spiritual protection or elevation.

מצאתי דרב חסדא כשהלך לבית
עולמו אזל רב יוסף בריה ובת
תמן על קבריה בלילא.[i] שמע
בגו קברא חדותא רבתא
דכתות כתות דמתכנשין
ואמרין ניזיל לחדותא הלולא
דאורייתא[ii] דרב חסדא ואפי׳
מלאכי השרת מתכנשי למחדי
בהדיה. שמע דהוו אמרין
מה לחייא בהדי דילן דלעי
באורייתא בההוא עלמא.[iii] אמר
ליה ברי זיל מהכא וקאים
תלמודא דזכאה איהו מאן דאתי
ותלמודיה בידיה[iv] דהא אפי׳
מלאכי השרת לא יכלי למקרבא
ליה. זיל ואימא ליה לרבי חגי
דיגמור תלמודיה דהא ביום
פלוני ייתי הכא. אדהכי דהוה
משתעי בהדיה סלקוהו לרב
חסדא למתיבתא עלאה. קם רב
יוסף בריה וחוי לחבריה אמרו
ליה אלמלא רב יוסף את ראוי
היית לעונש. אמר להו בגין
צערא דאבא אזלית תמן ושמעית

spent the night at his grave. He heard from within
the grave great rejoicing as groups gathered, saying, 105R
"Let us go to the joyous celebration of Torah[1] of
Rav Chisda!" Even the ministering angels gathered
to rejoice with him. He heard them saying, "What
business do the living have with us who study Torah
in that world?"[A] He said to his son, "My son, go 110R
away from here and continue your studies, for fortu-
nate is one who arrives [in the next world] with his
learning in hand,[2] for even the ministering angels
cannot approach him. Go and tell Rabbi Chagai to
complete his studies, for on a certain day he will come 115R
here." While he was still speaking with him, they
elevated Rav Chisda to the supernal academy. Rav
Yosef his son arose and told his companions what
happened. They said to him, "Were you not Rav
Yosef, you would deserve punishment." He replied 120R
to them, "Because of my grief for my father, I went
there and heard all this."

And if you contemplate with your mind's eye the
reason for the circuits [performed around the de-
ceased][3] that will be presented before us, you will 125R
understand something of the soul's elevation and its
reward after it has been offered as a sacrifice by

[A] Or: "What connection do the living have with our affairs, as we labor in Torah in that world?" — This alternative more precisely captures the Aramaic 'דלעי באורייתא' which connotes laborious effort or toil in Torah study, and clarifies the separation between the realms of the living and dead.

[3] The term 'hillula' (הלולא) literally means 'wedding celebration' and is used metaphorically to describe the joyous union between a righteous soul and the divine after death. This positive framing of death as celebration rather than tragedy is characteristic of kabbalistic thought.

[4] This reflects the rabbinic teaching that Torah learning is the only possession that accompanies a person after death. The phrase emphasizes the enduring value of spiritual accomplishments over material ones.

[1] These 'circuits' (hakafot) refer to the Jewish burial custom of circling the deceased's bier seven times before burial. The text suggests these ritual actions have mystical significance for the soul's journey after death.

[i] This recounts a narrative about Rav Yosef visiting his father's grave at night, in the tradition of numerous Talmudic and post-Talmudic stories about communication between the living and the dead. While such visits were sometimes discouraged for fear of non-Jewish necromantic practices, they were also seen as opportunities for pious connection.

[ii] The term 'hillula' (celebration) is used to describe the joyous spiritual state of a righteous person after death, conceptualizing death not as a tragedy but as a wedding-like union with the divine. This term is particularly associated with the anniversaries of deaths of great sages in Jewish mystical tradition.

[iii] This reveals the belief that Torah study continues in the afterlife, and at an even higher level than possible in the physical world. The phrase expresses the spiritual separation between the worlds of the living and the dead, despite their occasional communication.

[iv] This phrase echoes a Talmudic teaching (Pesachim 50a) that those who arrive in the next world with their learning intact receive special status. It emphasizes that intellectual and spiritual accomplishments are the only possessions that accompany a person after death.

כל האי. ואם תסתכל בעין השכל
בטעם ההקפות שיבאו לפנינו
תבין קצת משם עלוי הנשמה
ושכרה אחרי שנתקרבה קרבן
ע״י מיכאל השר הגדול[i] כי
מעצמה מתעלית ואורה יהל
כאור השמש בגבורתו עד כי
זוכה לשמש ברקיע ערבות
העליון ברוך אשר חלק מכבודו
ליראיו ואוי ואבוי למאבד
עצמו לדעת ומוציא כל ימיו
לאסוף הון לאחרים[ii] ואולי
לנושא אלמנתו. ואמרו בפ׳
תרומה דף קנ״ו על פתוריהן
דצדיקייא שאכילת הנשמות היא
דוגמת אכילת מלאכי השרת
הנזונים מכח החסד. ולכן
ירדו לאכול על שלחן אברהם
אבינו ע״ה מרכבה לחסד אל
ומעין אותו המזון אכלו ישראל
במדבר כדדרשו על פסוק לחם
אבירים אכל איש. ושם פירשו
מהו המזון הזה. עוד שם דף
קס״ו פירש מה הם הי״ש עלמין
דכסופא[iii] ועשור שלהם הוא שם
א״ל כנתבאר בשערי אורה. ושם
דף קכ״ז אמר כי ענג נשמתין
דלית להו גופא בהאי עלמא הוא

Michael, the great prince.[1] For it elevates itself, and its light shines like the brilliance of the sun in its strength, until it merits to serve in the firmament of the supernal Aravot.[2] Blessed is He who has apportioned of His glory to those who fear Him! But woe and alas to one who deliberately destroys himself and spends all his days amassing wealth for others, perhaps even for the one who will marry his widow. 135R

They said in Parashat Terumah, page 156, regarding the tables of the righteous, that the souls' consumption is similar to that of the ministering angels who are nourished by the power of Chesed (Loving-kindness). Therefore, they descended to eat at the table of our father Abraham, peace be upon him, who was a chariot for God's kindness, and from a source similar to that food, Israel ate in the wilderness, as they interpreted the verse, "Man ate the bread of the mighty." And there they explained what this food is. Furthermore, on page 166, it is explained what the 310 worlds of longing[A] are, and their tithe is the Divine name "El," as explained in Sha'arei Orah. And on page 127, it says that the delight of souls that have no body in this world comes from rivers of pure balsam oil,[3] while souls that ascend and have a body in this world draw sustenance from the illumination of the pavilion, which is Malkhut (Kingdom), and balsam corresponds to Binah (Understanding), and the discourse there is 130R 140R 145R 150R 155R

[A] Or: "310 worlds of yearning/desire" — The Aramaic 'כסופא' has connotations of yearning, shame, or desire that go beyond mere 'longing'. In kabbalistic contexts, it often refers to the soul's intense desire to return to its divine source, making this alternative potentially more precise in conveying the mystical concept.

[2] In Jewish mystical tradition, the archangel Michael serves as the heavenly high priest who offers the souls of the righteous as sacrifices before God's throne, creating a parallel between earthly death rituals and the heavenly Temple service.

[3] Aravot is the highest of the seven heavens in rabbinic cosmology, described as the dwelling place of God's glory, souls of the righteous, and the celestial Temple. The soul's ascent to this realm represents the highest possible spiritual achievement.

[4] These mystical 'rivers of balsam oil' (נהרי אפרסמונא דכיא) are described in the Talmud and expanded upon in kabbalistic literature as sources of spiritual pleasure and sustenance for righteous souls in the Garden of Eden.

[i] Michael is described as the 'great prince' who offers the souls of the righteous as sacrifices before God, similar to his role in rabbinic literature as the high priest of the heavenly Temple. This connects death rituals to Temple sacrificial service.

[ii] The text contrasts the spiritual rewards of the righteous with the fate of those who waste their lives pursuing material wealth. The phrase contains a wordplay in Hebrew between 'wealth' (הון/hon) and 'others' (אחרים/acherim), emphasizing the futility of material pursuits.

[i] The number 310 (י״ש) is significant in Kabbalah, representing the worlds reserved for the righteous in the afterlife. The term derives from Proverbs 8:21, 'To bequeath substance (יש/yesh) to those who love me,' and is connected to divine rewards.

מנהרי אפרסמונא דביא ונשמתין דסלקין ואית להו גופא בהאי עלמא ינקי מנהירו דאפריון שהוא מלכות ואפרסמון בינה והדרוש שם רחב. וכתוב בפ׳ מקץ שאחר עברת הנשמה בנהר דינור[i] שוב אין לה דין כלל. אשרי עין הזוכה לראות כל אלה:[ii]

extensive. And it is written in Parashat Miketz that after the soul passes through the River of Fire,[1] it is no longer subject to judgment at all. Fortunate is the eye that merits to see all this!

פרק י״ט

Chapter 19

סדר וידוי לשכיב מרע שהנהגתי בו[iii][iv]

Order of Confession for the Terminally Ill That I Instituted[2]

מנהגן של ישראל לאסוף עשרה אנשים למען רבים יבקשו עליו רחמים ובעשר נצוצי נשמותיהם

It is the custom of Israel to gather ten men[A] so that many may pray for mercy on behalf of the sick person, and through the ten sparks of their souls, they 5R

[A] Or: "to assemble a minyan (quorum of ten men)" — Using the Hebrew term 'minyan' would be more precise in capturing the religious significance of this gathering, though it might be less accessible to readers unfamiliar with Jewish terminology.

[1] The River of Fire (נהר דינור) serves as a purifying barrier through which souls must pass after death. This passage suggests that once this purification is complete, the soul is no longer subject to judgment, having been cleansed of all earthly impurities.

[2] The title indicates that Aaron Berechia of Modena is presenting his own personal arrangement for conducting the deathbed confession ritual, rather than simply reporting traditional practices.

[i] The 'River of Fire' appears in Daniel 7:10 and features prominently in Jewish mystical literature as a purifying barrier through which souls must pass after death. It serves to cleanse impurities before souls can enter higher spiritual realms.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Shelach — The reference establishes textual authority for the idea of celestial academies mirroring earthly ones, which is central to the text's vision of afterlife rewards for Torah scholars. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah — The citation builds on earlier passages about souls' reward to explain the specific mechanism of spiritual sustenance in the afterlife, connecting it to the attribute of Chesed (Divine Loving-kindness). | Cf. Psalms 78:25 — This biblical reference serves to connect the physical nourishment of manna with the spiritual nourishment of souls in the afterlife, suggesting that both originate from the same divine source of Chesed. | Cf. Sha'arei Orah — The reference to this classic kabbalistic text provides doctrinal background for understanding the connection between the 310 worlds and the divine name 'El', establishing a framework for interpreting the soul's posthumous experience. | Cf. Hakafot ritual — The reference to 'circuits' (hakafot) that will be 'presented before us' suggests that the text will later explain this funeral ritual, indicating it has spiritual significance for the soul's elevation after death.

[iii] The author is presenting his personal method for conducting the deathbed confession ritual (vidui), indicating this is his own practice rather than simply reporting traditional methods.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author is presenting his own specific arrangement for the deathbed confession ritual, which may differ slightly from other traditional formulations while maintaining the same essential purpose. | Cf. Talmud Bavli — The author is basing his practice on the Talmudic requirement for deathbed confession, while expanding it with kabbalistic elements about the soul's journey. | Cf. Zohar — The author incorporates Zoharic concepts about the Divine Presence's attendance at deathbeds into practical ritual instructions. | Cf. Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah — The author directly quotes this midrash to establish biblical and rabbinic precedent for the practice of deathbed confession.

יסלקו ממנו כל מסטין ומעיק
כי הקדושה שורה בתוכם בסוד
ונקדשתי בתוך בני ישראל וכל
מקום שמתקבצים עשרה מישראל
לדבר שבקדושה המקום ההוא
יקרא בית הכנסת ירצה מקום
כניסת האורות מעשרה שליטים
עליונים כמו שהם נכנסים כלם
בתוך המלכות הנקראת בית
הכנסת ע״י יסוד בן מתאחדים
במקום הנועדים שם לקדש שם
שמים בכח נשמותיהם כנזכר.
ובמקום שיש שם חולה בעל
תשובה שכינה קדמא ואתיא[i] ועל
כן הקב״ה בעצמו סועד אותו
כדכתיב ה׳ יסעדנו על ערש דוי
ובזה אין שם שטן ולא פגע רע
כי כחמס דונג מפני אש יאבדו
רשעים מפני אלהים ולעורר
שפע יסודו של עולם שהוא
אשר הנחלים על בן הוידוי
של שביב מרע אומר אותו ע״י
סרסור[ii] שהחכם מקרא אותו מלה
במלה ועוד שאין חבוש מתיר
עצמו מבית האסורים.[iii] ואמרו
במדרש במדבר רבה פ׳ ח׳
על פסוק ואשמה הנפש ההיא
והתודו ר׳ נתן אומר זה בנה
אב לכל המתים שטעונין וידוי.
אין במשמע וידוי אלא בארץ
מנין אף בגלות אמרת והתודו
את עונם ואת עון אבותם וגו׳.
וכן בדניאל הוא אומר לך ה׳
הצדקה וגו׳ מפני מה כי חטאנו
לך. ויבוין המודה החולה שנעשה

will remove from him all accusers and afflictions,[A] for holiness dwells among them, according to the mystery of "I will be sanctified among the children of Israel." Any place where ten Israelites gather for a sacred purpose is called a synagogue, meaning a 10R
place where the lights from the ten supernal rulers enter, just as they all enter into Malkhut (which is called the synagogue) through Yesod. Similarly, they unite in the place where they gather to sanctify God's name through the power of their souls,[B] as 15R
mentioned. In a place where there is a penitent sick person, the Divine Presence precedes and arrives, and therefore the Holy One, blessed be He, Himself sustains him, as it is written, "The Lord will sustain him upon his sickbed." In this situation, there is 20R
neither Satan nor evil occurrence, for "as wax melts before fire, so shall the wicked perish before God." To awaken the flow from the Foundation of the world, which is the outpouring of rivers, the confession of the deathly ill person is recited through an intermediary, with the sage reciting it word by word, for a 25R
prisoner cannot free himself from prison.

They said in the Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah, Chapter 8, regarding the verse "And that soul shall be guilty, and they shall confess": Rabbi Nathan 30R
says this establishes a precedent that all who die require confession. How do we know that confession applies not only in the Land but also in exile? As it says, "And they shall confess their iniquity and the iniquity of their fathers, etc." And so in Daniel it 35R
says, "To You, O Lord, belongs righteousness, etc." Why? "Because we have sinned against You."

The sick person making confession should intend to become a channel to cleanse the blemish and darkness that was caused in the sefirot through his sins, 40R

[B] Or: "they will dispel all spiritual prosecutors and distresses from him" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the mystical concept that these are not merely physical afflictions but spiritual entities or forces that 'prosecute' the soul.

[C] Or: "through the spiritual potency of their souls" — This alternative emphasizes the mystical understanding that souls possess active spiritual power capable of affecting metaphysical realities.

[i] This Aramaic expression literally means "the Divine Presence precedes and arrives," a concept from the Zohar indicating that for a penitent, especially one who is ill, the Divine Presence hastens to arrive before being called upon—reflecting special divine favor toward those who repent.

[ii] The author introduces an important practical instruction that the deathbed confession should be facilitated by an intermediary (usually a learned person) who recites it word by word for the dying person to repeat. This reflects the Jewish belief that proper guidance is needed at this critical spiritual moment.

[iii] This phrase alludes to a Talmudic principle that "a prisoner cannot free himself from prison" (Berakhot 5b), metaphorically suggesting that someone overwhelmed by illness or the approach of death requires outside assistance for spiritual liberation.

גם הוא סניף למרק הפגם והחשך שנפגם בספירות[i] ע״י החטאים של החולה בכח תשובתו ויסורין שסובל כי הכל לטוב ואפי׳ מדת עונשין אינה אלא למרק הרע ולהחזירו למוטב ויכוונו שניהם בזה להרפות הדינים בתחלת מציאותן בכח השפעת ארוכה מכתר מצנור המיוחד לו לבינה ולהחליש הדינים בחג״ת ולבטלן בנצח הוד יסוד כמו שדרשו גורי האר״י בסוד שלשה מיני תקיעות הנעשים בראש השנה. בראשונה אחר שזרזו המודה ותקן מעשיו ומחל לכל אשר צערו מיום היותו יאמר הודוי הכתוב לעיל ואם ירצה להאריך יאמר אחריו על חטא וסדר הודוי אשר הצעתי בלילי אשמורות בסדר יום ראשון במעירי שחר[ii] שהוא מסוגל לאומרו. ושמעתי כי שלמים וכן רבים מקרין אותו אדון עולם עד תומו. ויש מקרין אותו יגדל ומפרשים לו כל אחד מי״ג עקרים אם צריך לכך והשכיב מרע יודה בפיו ובלבבו על כל אחד מהם והכל לפי ישוב דעתו של חולה וטוב מעט בכונה מהרבות בלא כונה.[iii]

through the power of his repentance and the suffering he endures. For everything is for good, and even the attribute of punishment is only to cleanse away evil and return one to good. Both (the sick person and the guide) should intend to weaken the judgments at their inception through the influence of healing from Keter through the channel designated for Binah, to weaken the judgments in Chesed-Gevurah-Tiferet, and to nullify them in Netzach-Hod-Yesod, as the disciples of the Ari explained regarding the mystery of the three types of shofar blasts made on Rosh Hashanah. 45R 50R

First, after the guide has encouraged the sick person, who has rectified his actions and forgiven all who have caused him distress from the day of his birth, he should recite the confession written above. If he wishes to elaborate, he may recite afterward the "Al Chet" prayer and the order of confession which I have set forth in the night watches in the first day order in my "Me'irei Shachar," which is particularly suitable to recite. I have heard that many complete it by reciting "Adon Olam" to its conclusion. Some recite "Yigdal" and explain to him each of the Thirteen Principles of Faith if necessary, and the sick person acknowledges each one verbally and in his heart. Everything depends on the mental state of the sick person, and a little with proper intention is better than much without intention. 55R 60R 65R

אחר הוידוי הנזכר[iv] יאמר

After the aforementioned confession, he should re-

[i] This reflects a core kabbalistic concept that human actions affect the divine realms (sefirot). The confession of the sick person is understood not merely as personal atonement but as participation in cosmic repair (tikkun), cleansing damage caused by sin in the upper worlds.

[ii] "Me'irei Shachar" (Illuminators of Dawn) was a prayer collection compiled by the author, Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena. He references his own work as a source for the appropriate confession formulas, indicating his role as a liturgical innovator.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse, Siftei Tzedek section — This passage elaborates on the proper procedures for deathbed confession (vidui) that are introduced earlier in the book, providing specific instructions for the ritual leader and explaining the mystical significance of having ten men present. | Cf. Zohar — The passage incorporates several Zoharic concepts, particularly the idea that the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) 'precedes and arrives' (קדמא ואתיא) for penitents, and the notion that confession repairs damage in the upper worlds/sefirot. | Cf. Teachings of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the Ari) — The passage references the teachings of the disciples of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the Ari) regarding the mystical significance of the shofar blasts on Rosh Hashanah and applies this system to understanding how confession and suffering can repair spiritual damage in the upper worlds. | Cf. Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah, Chapter 8 — This direct quotation establishes the textual basis for the requirement of deathbed confession, showing how the author grounds mystical practices in traditional rabbinic texts. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author references his own prayer compilation 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), indicating that the confession texts prescribed here are consistent with the liturgical materials he developed elsewhere.

[i] This refers to the deathbed confession (vidui) ritual that was described in previous sections. The

הרבון הכתוב למעלה פרק ט״ו[i] ואם יוכל להאריך יאמר אח״כ זה:[ii]

cite the "Master of the Universe"[1] prayer written above in Chapter 16, and if he is able to continue at length,[2] he should then say this: 70R

תּוֹדִיעֵנִי אוֹרַח חַיִּים[iii] שׂוֹבַע
שְׂמָחוֹת אֶת פָּנֶיךָ נְעִימוֹת בִּימִינְךָ
נֶצַח: וְיָדַעְתָּ הַיּוֹם וַהֲשֵׁבוֹתָ אֶל
לְבָבֶךָ[iv] כִּי יְיָ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים
בַּשָּׁמַיִם מִמַּעַל וְעַל הָאָרֶץ
מִתָּחַת אֵין עוֹד: יְיָ אֱלֹהִים אֱמֶת
וּמשֶׁה אֱמֶת וְתוֹרָתוֹ אֱמֶת:[v] ג׳
פעמים[vi] עָזְרֵנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ
עַל דְּבַר כְּבוֹד שְׁמֶךָ שֶׁיִּתְקַדֵּשׁ
וְיִתְיַחֵד עַל יָדֵינוּ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד
וַהֲצִילֵנוּ וְכַפֵּר עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ לְמַעַן
שְׁמֶךָ: שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְיָ

"You will make known to me the path of life; in Your presence is fullness of joy, at Your right hand are pleasures forevermore. And you shall know today and take it to heart that the LORD is God in heaven above and on earth below; there is none else. The LORD God is truth, and Moses is truth, and His Torah is truth." [Recite] three times:[3] "Help us, O God of our salvation, for the sake of the glory of Your name,[4] that it may be sanctified and unified through us[5] forever and ever, and save us and atone for our sins for Your name's sake. Hear, O Israel:[6] The LORD our God, the LORD is One. Blessed be the 75R 80R

[1]The original text uses 'ha-ribbono' (הרבון), which refers to a specific prayer beginning with the words 'Ribbono shel Olam' (Master of the Universe). This is a standard form of address to God in Jewish prayers, particularly in personal supplications.

[2]This instruction shows sensitivity to the dying person's condition, acknowledging that they might be too weak to recite lengthy prayers. The text offers a shorter alternative while providing an option for those with sufficient strength.

[3]The instruction to recite the following prayer three times reflects the Jewish liturgical practice of threefold repetition for emphasis and spiritual power. This is particularly significant in deathbed rituals where such repetitions are believed to create spiritual protection for the departing soul.

[4]This phrase reflects the kabbalistic concept that human actions can directly affect divine realms, with proper prayer 'unifying' fragmented aspects of divinity. In Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, the deathbed confession and prayers serve not just personal salvation but cosmic repair.

[5]This reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'yichud' (unification), suggesting that proper prayer at the moment of death helps unify the divine name and attributes in higher realms, a central mystical concept in Ma'avar Yabok.

[1]The Shema prayer represents the pinnacle of Jewish deathbed ritual. Ma'avar Yabok, following kabbalistic tradition, considers its recitation to facilitate 'death by divine kiss' (mittat neshikah), the most elevated form of death where the soul departs in mystical union with God.

confession is considered essential for proper spiritual preparation for death in Jewish tradition.

[ii]This refers to Chapter 16 of the first discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, which contains the full text of the 'Ribbono' prayer (Master of the Universe) that is to be recited after the confession ritual.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 16 — The text references a prayer titled 'Ribbono' (Master of the Universe) that appears in Chapter 16 of Ma'avar Yabok. This is a standard prayer recitation instruction within the deathbed ritual sequence, directing the reader to a previously established prayer text rather than repeating it in full. | Cf. Vidui (Confession) — The text refers to 'the aforementioned confession' (ha-vidui ha-nizkar), indicating that this instruction follows a standardized confession ritual for the dying that would have been detailed earlier in the book. Vidui is central to Jewish deathbed practices and is considered essential for spiritual preparation for death.

[iv]This verse is from Psalm 16:11, traditionally recited by the dying person or by those attending them. It emphasizes divine guidance and the hope for eternal joy in God's presence after death.

[v]From Deuteronomy 4:39, this verse affirms God's absolute sovereignty and unity, a central theological affirmation for someone approaching death.

[vi]This is a traditional affirmation of faith, not directly from the Bible but a rabbinic formulation combining several concepts. It serves as a declaration of core Jewish beliefs at the moment of death.

[vii]This instruction indicates that the following prayer should be recited three times, a common practice in Jewish liturgy to emphasize importance.

אֶחָד:[i] בָּרוּךְ שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:[ii iii]

name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever."[1] 85R

ופסוק שמע הוא שמירה לאדם מלפנים. ויושב בסתר עליון היא שמירה מצד ימין. ה׳ מה רבו צרי שמירה שמאל: יברכך וגו׳ עד סוף ברכת כהנים היא שמירה מאחוריו. אמנם עיקר השמירה היא בשם מ״ב שהוא מהבינה וכן הנשמה מבינה[iv] וקושרה למעלה ומעלה לשרשיו ותיבותיו שבעה והם שבעה שרפים ואותיות תבותיו ששה הם שש כנפים אשר בהם תעוף הנשמה בשמים באין שטן ואין פגע רע.[v] ברוך ה׳ צבאות אלהינו שבראנו לכבודו

The verse of Shema provides protection for a person from the front.[2] "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High" is protection from the right side.[A] "O LORD, how many are my foes" is protection from the left. "May the LORD bless you," etc., until the end of the Priestly Blessing, provides protection from behind. However, the primary protection comes from the 42-letter Name, which derives from Binah, as does the soul, and it binds the soul upward to its roots. Its words are seven in number, representing the seven Seraphim, and the letters of its words are six, representing six wings, with which the soul flies through the heavens without Satan and without evil harm. 90R 95R

[A] Or: "And [the psalm] "He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High" provides protection from the right side" — The Hebrew text is referring specifically to Psalm 91, so making this explicit helps clarify the reference to specific psalms that provide directional protection.

[2] This response to the Shema creates a theological symmetry: the Shema affirms God's unity above, while this response acknowledges God's kingdom below, completing the cosmic circuit that helps transport the soul through spiritual realms after death.

[3] The text is presenting a comprehensive system of directional protection through specific biblical verses, with each verse guarding against spiritual dangers from a different direction, similar to the concept of the four archangels protecting different sides.

[i] The Shema, from Deuteronomy 6:4, is Judaism's central declaration of faith in God's unity. Reciting it at death was considered especially meritorious, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited it during his martyrdom.

[ii] This response to the Shema is recited silently during regular prayer but spoken aloud on Yom Kippur and at the moment of death, connecting the dying person to the holiest day of the year.

[iii] Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4-9 — The Shema is Judaism's central declaration of faith, traditionally recited at the moment of death. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes its recitation as facilitating the soul's peaceful departure through mystical union with God, particularly when recited with proper kavvanah (intention). | Cf. Psalm 16:11 — This psalm verse expresses hope for divine guidance beyond death and the joy of eternal presence with God. Its placement at the beginning of this deathbed prayer establishes a positive theological framework for death as a transition to divine presence rather than an end. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 35 — Elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 35 provides detailed instructions about proper spiritual intentions (kavvanot) at the time of death, particularly through recitation of the Shema prayer and meditation on divine names to facilitate the soul's transition. | Cf. Zohar I:88a — The Zohar, a primary source for Ma'avar Yabok, describes how the Shema creates spiritual protection during sleep (considered 'one-sixtieth of death') and actual death. This prayer reflects that kabbalistic understanding of the Shema as a protective formula during the soul's transition. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 61b — Rabbi Akiva's recitation of the Shema during his martyrdom became the model for proper death with sanctification of the divine name. Ma'avar Yabok repeatedly references this example as the ideal approach to death, making the inclusion of the Shema here particularly significant.

[iv] This passage presents a key kabbalistic concept that both the 42-letter Divine Name and the human soul originate from the same divine source (the sefirah of Binah, 'Understanding'), explaining why this particular Name is especially effective for soul protection.

[i] The author draws a parallel between the structure of the 42-letter Name (7 words of 6 letters each) and the angelic seraphim (who have 6 wings each), suggesting that this Name enables the soul to ascend like these angels, bypassing demonic interference.

וברוך אל אלים ואלהי האלהים
ומלך עולם. ה׳ הוא האלהים ה׳
הוא האלהים. מיוחד אהי״ה אשר
אהי״ה הוא היה והוא הוה והוא
יהיה ה׳ אל אמת. ה׳ מלך ה׳
מלך ה׳ ימלוך לעולם ועד. והיה
ה׳ למלך על כל הארץ ביום
ההוא יהיה ה׳ אחד ושמו אחד.
ברוך ה׳ אלהי ישראל מהעולם
ועד העולם אמן ואמן. אח״כ
יאמר עם החולה ב׳ פסוקים
הראשונים ממזמור אשא עיני אל
ההרים והעומדים עליו יבקשו
עליו רחמים עם תשלום המזמור
וכן יעשה ג״פ ופסוק ה׳ ישמור
צאתך ובואך מסוגל לשמירה
למי שיצטרך לצאת חוצה מרשות
הקדושה ויסתכן מפני שנכנס
למקום החצונים ונכלל בזה
היוצא מביתו בלילה. והנשמה
היוצאת מן הגוף בעת השינה
וכן ביוצא ח״ל אפי׳ לדבר
מצוה וא״צ לומר הנשמה בעת
יציאתה מן העולם. על כל אלה
צריכים תפלה כי ישמרו בצאתם
ובבואם מעתה שהיא מלכות
ועד עולם. ועד בבינה עולם
העליון שעד שם הגעת הדינים
ואחיזת החצונים ומשם ולמעלה
אין דין ואין אחיזה לשום דבר
פגום חס ושלום. וה׳ ישמור את
נפשך פירשוהו ברבה פ׳ ס״ח על
שמירתה ממלאך המות. ואמרו
בזהר אם יזכה בר נש ויהיה צדיק
וידע שמא דקוב״ה מה יומרון
לי׳ בעדנא דמסתלק מעלמא.
לא תירא מפחד לילה מחץ יעוף
יומם וגו׳. עד אשגבהו כי ידע
שמי. הנה כי טוב לחולה להרגיל
עצמו גם במזמור יושב בסתר
עליון. ואח״כ יאמר י״ג מדות
דאריך שמשם ארוכה ומרפא

Blessed is the LORD of hosts, our God, who created us for His glory, and blessed is God of gods, and God of all gods, and King of the universe. The LORD, He is God; the LORD, He is God. Uniquely, "I AM THAT I AM," He was, He is, and He will be, the LORD, God of truth. The LORD reigns, the LORD has reigned, the LORD will reign forever and ever. And the LORD shall be King over all the earth; on that day the LORD will be One and His name One. Blessed is the LORD, God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting, Amen and Amen. 100R 105R 110R

Afterward, recite with the sick person the first two verses from Psalm 121, "I lift up my eyes to the mountains," and those standing nearby should pray for mercy on his behalf with the completion of the psalm.[1] Do this three times. The verse "The LORD will guard your going out and your coming in" is especially beneficial as protection for one who needs to go outside the domain of holiness and is endangered because he enters the realm of external forces. This includes one who leaves his home at night, or the soul leaving the body during sleep, or one who leaves the Holy Land even for the sake of a commandment, and needless to say, the soul at the time of its departure from the world. For all these, prayer is needed that they may be protected in their going out and coming in from now, which is Malkhut, until forever.[2] "Until" refers to Binah, the supernal world, for up to there judgments reach and external forces can take hold, but from there and above there is no judgment and no hold for anything flawed, God forbid. 115R 120R 125R 130R

"The LORD will preserve your soul" was interpreted in Rabbah, chapter 68, as preservation from the Angel of Death. And they said in the Zohar, "If a person merits and becomes righteous and knows the Name of the Holy One, blessed be He, what will be said to him at the time of his departure from the world? 'You shall not fear the terror of night, nor the arrow that flies by day,'" etc., until "I will set him on high because he knows My name." Thus, it is good for the sick person to accustom himself also 135R 140R

[1] This reflects the Jewish communal approach to healing, where the sick person recites the beginning of the psalm while the community completes it, creating a spiritual partnership in the healing process.

[2] The text interprets the phrase 'from now until forever' in kabbalistic terms, where 'now' represents Malkhut (the lowest divine attribute) and 'forever' represents Binah (a higher divine attribute), suggesting that protection spans the entire divine realm from lowest to highest.

תעלה לו והם ג׳ פסוקים.[i] מי אל
כמוך א׳. נושא עון ב׳. ועובר
על פשע ג׳. לשארית נחלתו ד׳.
לא החזיק לעד אפו ה׳. כי חפץ
חסד הוא ו׳. ישוב ירחמנו ז׳.
יכבוש עונותינו ח׳. ותשליך
במצולות ים כל חטאתם ט׳. תתן
אמת ליעקב י׳. חסד לאברהם
י״א. כאשר נשבעת לאבותינו
י״ב. מימי קדם י״ג. ועיין
מזה בתומר דבורה שהוא תמר
האחרון מע׳ תמרים אשר נטע
ושתל המקובל האלהי כמוהר״ר
משה קורדואיר״ו זצוק״ל מלבד
הדרושים המופלאים אשר דרש
על סוד י״ג מקורות רחמים
עליונים אלו בשאר התמרים
בחכמה רבה והם מסוגלים מאד
לאמרם ביום הכפורים אחר כל
אחד מהכ״ו ויעבור הנאמרים
באותו יום ובן הנהגתי בבית
הכנסת שלנו[ii] כי הם בכחם
הנאדרי שהם רחמים פשוטים
מא״א ממתיקים י״ג מדות של ז״א
שהם רחמים סתם והיום ההוא
א״ך טוב לישראל בגימטריא
אהי״ה וכוונת התפלה תהיה בכח
שם הוי״ה בנקודת אלהים ושם
הוי״ה נקוד קמץ כי כן בינה
מושפעת מכ״ע ולכן מעוררים
הכ״ו כל״ח שהם בהלל הגדול
והכ״בוד מתעלה ואם הבנים
שמחה בהלול י״ה. אח״כ יאמר
עם המתודה פסוק בידך אפקיד
רוחי פדית אותי ה׳ אל אמת.
יסרני ה׳ אך במשפט אל באפך

to Psalm 91, “He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High.”

Then he should recite the Thirteen Attributes of Arikh Anpin, from which healing and remedy arise for him, and they are in three verses: (1) “Who is a God like You,” (2) “Who pardons iniquity,” (3) “And passes over transgression,”[A] (4) “For the remnant of His heritage,” (5) “He does not maintain His anger forever,” (6) “For He delights in mercy,” (7) “He will again have compassion on us,” (8) “He will subdue our iniquities,” (9) “And You will cast all their sins into the depths of the sea,” (10) “You will give truth to Jacob,” (11) “Mercy to Abraham,” (12) “As You have sworn to our fathers,” (13) “From days of old.” Refer to Tomer Devorah, which is the last palm tree of the seventy palm trees that the divine Kabbalist, our teacher Rabbi Moses Cordovero, of blessed and holy memory, planted, besides the wondrous discourses which he expounded on the secret of these thirteen sources of supernal mercy in the other palm trees, with great wisdom. They are highly beneficial to recite on Yom Kippur after each of the twenty-six recitations of “And the LORD passed by” said on that day, and this is the practice I established in our synagogue. For these, in their majestic power, are simple mercies from Arikh Anpin, which sweeten the Thirteen Attributes of Zeir Anpin, which are ordinary mercies. And that day is “only good for Israel,” whose numerical value equals that of the Name Ehyeh, and the intention of the prayer should be with the power of the Name YHVH with the vowel points of Elohim, and the Name YHVH vocalized with kamatz, for thus is Binah influenced from Keter,[1] and therefore we arouse the twenty-six, thirty-eight times, which are in the Great Hallel, and the glory is elevated, and the mother of children

145R 150R 155R 160R 165R 170R 175R

[A] Or: “(1) “Who is a God like You,” (2) “Who bears iniquity,” (3) “And passes over transgression,”” — The Hebrew ‘nosa avon’ is often translated as ‘bears iniquity’ or ‘forgives iniquity’ in biblical contexts, which might be more familiar to some readers.

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of divine flow, where the sefirah of Binah (Understanding) receives influence from Keter (Crown), the highest divine emanation. The vowel points mentioned are believed to channel this spiritual energy appropriately.

[i] The text distinguishes between the Thirteen Attributes revealed to Moses (Exodus 34:6-7) and these alternative Thirteen Attributes of Arikh Anpin (the kabbalistic ‘Long-Faced One,’ representing a higher level of divinity), which are drawn from verses in Micah 7:18-20.

[ii] The author reveals his role as a synagogue leader who instituted specific liturgical practices based on kabbalistic teachings, showing how Ma’avar Yabok blends theoretical mysticism with practical communal ritual leadership.

180 פן תמעיטני. בטוב תלין ותקין
ברחמים. ויכוין כי טו״ב תלי״ן
בגימטריא אבגי״תץ עם הכולל
ותקי״ץ ברחמי״ם בגימטריא
שקו״צית[i] ויכוין לכלול הארת
185 כל השם הגדול הזה בנפשו
רוחו ונשמתו שבעולם העשיה
להעלותם ובצל שדי יתלוננו.
אל נא רפא נא לי (ג״פ). ואם
ירצה להוסיף אל מלך ובפרט
190 אם הוא ת״ח מה טוב. ויאמר
תחלה אתאנו על שמך וגו׳.
וכן פסוק רפאני ה׳ וארפא
הושיעני ואושעה כי תהלתי
אתה. אל תעזבני ה׳ אלהי אל
195 תרחק ממני חושה לעזרתי ה׳
תשועתי. לישועתך קויתי ה׳.
ה׳ לישועתך קויתי. קויתי ה׳
לישועתך. ואמרו שכל פסוק
שהוא הפוך וישר כזה הוא טוב
200 לשמירה כי הוא חרב פיפיות נגד
המקטרגים.[ii] יברכך וגו׳ עד
סוף ברכת כהנים. יהיו לרצון
וגו׳. ואם ירצה החכם יכול
להוסיף סדר הודוי שהדפסנו
205 במעירי שחר שלנו בסדר יום
ראשון:[iii]

rejoices in praising Yah.

Afterward, recite with the one confessing the verse “Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth.” “Chasten me, O LORD, but in justice; not in Your anger, lest You diminish me.” “You will rest in goodness and awaken with mercy.” One should have in mind that “You will rest in goodness” equals in gematria ABGITATZ with the inclusive value,[1] and “awaken with mercy” equals in gematria SHKUTZIT, and one should intend to include the illumination of this entire great Name in his nefesh, ruach, and neshamah, which are in the world of Asiyah, to elevate them,[2] and they will abide in the shadow of the Almighty. “Please God, heal me” (three times). And if one wishes to add “El Melekh,” especially if he is a Torah scholar, that is good. He should first say “We have come for the sake of Your name,” etc. And also the verse “Heal me, O LORD, and I shall be healed; save me, and I shall be saved, for You are my praise.” “Do not forsake me, O LORD, my God; do not be far from me. Hasten to help me, O LORD, my salvation.” “For Your salvation I wait, O LORD.” “O LORD, for Your salvation I wait.” “I wait, O LORD, for Your salvation.” And they said that any verse that reads the same backward and forward like this is good for protection, for it is like

180R 185R 190R 195R 200R

[2]This demonstrates gematria, the practice of finding meaning in the numerical values of Hebrew words. The text instructs the reader to meditate on these equivalences to activate the spiritual power of divine names during the healing prayer.

[3]According to Kabbalah, the human soul has three main parts (nefesh, ruach, and neshamah) that reside in different spiritual worlds. This prayer aims to elevate all three soul levels from Asiyah (the physical world) to higher divine realms through the power of the 42-letter Name.

[i]This demonstrates a classic kabbalistic technique of gematria (numerical equivalence), where the Hebrew words טוב תלין (‘You will rest in goodness’) equal the numerical value of אבגיתץ (the first word of the 42-letter Name) when adding 1 for the word itself (כולל), while תקין ברחמים (‘awaken with mercy’) equals שקוצית (another mystical name).

[ii]The text explains the mystical power of palindromic verses in Hebrew (those that can be read forward and backward), comparing them to double-edged swords that cut in both directions against spiritual accusers.

[iii]Cf. Tomer Devorah — The author references Tomer Devorah (Palm Tree of Deborah) as an authoritative source on the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, indicating that the recitation of these attributes follows Cordovero’s kabbalistic interpretation of their mystical effects. | Cf. Psalm 121 — The text prescribes reciting the first verses of Psalm 121 (‘I lift my eyes to the mountains’) with the sick person, followed by others completing the psalm as a prayer for divine protection. This psalm was traditionally considered especially powerful for spiritual protection. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The text recommends Psalm 91 (‘He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High’) as beneficial for the sick person to recite regularly. This psalm was traditionally considered the most potent for protection against harmful spiritual forces and was specifically recited in contexts of danger and illness. | Cf. Zohar — The author cites the Zohar to establish that knowledge of divine names provides spiritual protection at the time of death, showing how Ma’avar Yabok draws its authority

a double-edged sword against accusers. "May the LORD bless you," etc., until the end of the Priestly Blessing. "May the words of my mouth," etc. And if the sage wishes, he may add the order of confession that we printed in our Me'irei Shachar for the first day:[A] 205R 210R

פרק כ׳

Chapter 20

יפה תפלה לחולה בחליו. ולכן בכל עת אל ימנע עצמו מן הרחמים כפי כחו וידיעתו בפסוקי דרחמי כאותם אשר הצענו לפני רבים. ועקר גדול למתפללים בצערם ומתחננים לכוין מה שאמר דוד המלך ע״ה[i] עמו אנכי בצרה ועל זאת יתפלל כל חסיד לעת מצא לעת מצוי הנכש ולעת מצוי החשבון. ואם אינו יכול בפיו יהרהר בלבו כדאמרו על פסוק אמרו בלבבכם על משכבכם ואם תזכו להפטר ולדמות (פי׳ מלשון שתיקה)[ii] תזכו סל״ה. פי׳ להתעלות עד חסד של עתיקא קדישא הנקרא סלה.[iii] ואם יובל להרגיל עצמו לקרות סדר

Prayer is beneficial for the sick person during his illness.[1] Therefore, at all times, one should not withhold mercy from oneself according to one's strength and knowledge of verses of compassion, like those we have presented before many. A fundamental principle for those who pray in their distress and supplicate is to focus on what King David, peace be upon him, said: "I am with him in distress,"[2] and "For this shall every pious one pray at a time of finding"[3]—at the time when the soul is accessible and at the time of reckoning. If one cannot vocalize prayers, one should contemplate them in one's heart, as they said regarding the verse: "Speak in your hearts upon your beds,"[4] and if you merit to depart and be silent (interpreted from the language of silence), you will merit Selah—meaning to be elevated to the loving-kindness of the Ancient Holy One, which is called "Selah." And if one can accustom oneself to recite the 5R 10R 15R

[A] Or: "in our 'Illuminators of Dawn' prayer book in the first day's order" — Translating the name 'Me'irei Shachar' helps readers understand it refers to a prayer book compiled by the author called 'Illuminators of Dawn'.

[1] This opening sentence establishes one of Ma'avar Yabok's central themes: the spiritual efficacy of prayer during illness, a concept that will be developed throughout the work.
[2] This quote from Psalms 91:15 is foundational to Jewish theological understanding of suffering, suggesting that divine presence is especially accessible during times of distress.
[3] This phrase from Psalms 32:6 is interpreted in rabbinic tradition to refer to special times when prayer is particularly effective, including moments of illness when the soul is more receptive.
[4] This reference to Psalms 4:5 supports the idea that even silent prayer or meditation has spiritual efficacy, which would be especially relevant for those too weak to vocalize prayers.

from canonical kabbalistic texts. | Cf. 42-letter Name of God — The text emphasizes the special protective power of the 42-letter Divine Name, explaining its structure (7 words with 6 letters each) and correspondence to angelic beings (seraphim with six wings). This name is particularly associated with the sefirah of Binah and is understood to elevate the soul to its divine source.
[i] This is an abbreviation for 'alav ha-shalom' (peace be upon him), a honorific used after mentioning a deceased sage.
[ii] The author provides his own interpretation here, explaining that the word 'demot' refers to silence or stillness, not to resemblance.
[i] This explanation reveals the author's kabbalistic interpretation of the word 'Selah' that appears in Psalms, connecting it to the divine attribute of loving-kindness (Chesed) within the Atika Kadisha (Ancient Holy One), a reference to the highest divine realm in Kabbalah.

פטום הקטרת בכוונה ולפחות
הפסוקים שלפניו מויאמר ה׳ אל
משה עד לפני ה׳ לדורותיכם
זה יהיה לו סיוע גדול להקל
מעליו חליו או להקטיר נשמתו
קטרת לפני ה׳ אם כן גזר עליו
היוצר: ולפנינו בזה יבא סדר
פטום הקטרת עם קצת מהכוונה
הנאותה בו בעה״י.[i] וירגיל
ג״כ עצמו כל מי שנפל למשכב
להתודות אחר כל ג׳ תפלותיו
כמו שעושים ביום הכפורים
וא״צ לומר קודם השכיבנו וזה
עקר גדול להתודות ולקבל
עליו החולי והיסורין לכפרת
עונותיו. ונאמר למהרר״י קאר״ו
זצ״ל[ii] כי כל כך זוכה אדם
ביסורין הבאים עליו כשסובלם
בסבר פנים יפות כמו שזוכה
בעשיית המצוה. והטעם שע״י
היסורין הגוף מתחלש שהוא כח
הטומאה כי הגוף מעור הנחש
פי׳ חומריי ונוטה לרצון הנחש
השולט בעה״ז[iii] והכסיל אוכל
את בשרו[iv] דוקא לא ח״ו הנשמה.
ובזה מזדככת הנפש מטומאתה
ונשארת טהורה ונקיה ומוכנת
להתלבש מכתנות אור דשבקת
בגן עדן תחתון שהיתה לבושה
בהם אחר רדתה מהיכל לבנת
הספיר בעת אשר נשתהתה שם

order of the preparation of the incense[5] with proper intention, or at least the verses before it from "And the LORD said to Moses" until "before the LORD throughout your generations," this will be of great assistance in alleviating one's illness, or to offer one's soul as incense before the LORD if the Creator has so decreed.

Before us, the order of the preparation of the incense will be presented with some of the appropriate intentions, God willing. Anyone who has fallen ill should also accustom themselves to confess after each of their three daily prayers,[1] as is done on Yom Kippur, and there is no need to recite it before the "Hashkiveinu" prayer. This is a fundamental principle: to confess and accept upon oneself the illness and suffering as atonement for one's sins. It was said to our teacher Rabbi Joseph Karo, of blessed memory, that a person merits as much through the sufferings that come upon him when he endures them with a pleasant countenance as he merits through the performance of a commandment.

The reason is that through sufferings, the body is weakened, which is the power of impurity, for the body is from the skin of the serpent—meaning it is material and inclines toward the desire of the serpent that rules in this world, and "the fool consumes his flesh" specifically, not the soul, God forbid. Through this, the soul is purified from its impurity and remains pure and clean, ready to be clothed in garments of light that it left in the lower Garden of Eden,[2] which it wore after descending from the

[1]The Pitum HaKetoret (Preparation of the Incense) is a liturgical text describing the Temple incense offering. In Kabbalistic tradition, reciting this text is believed to have protective and healing properties.

[2]The practice of regular confession (vidui) is normally associated with Yom Kippur, but Ma'avar Yabok recommends it as a daily practice for the ill, reflecting the book's emphasis on spiritual preparation for potential death.

[1]This refers to the kabbalistic concept of spiritual garments (levushim) that the soul possesses in different realms. The 'lower Garden of Eden' refers to the first level of paradise that souls experience after death.

[i]This is an abbreviation for 'be-ezrat Hashem yitbarach' (with the help of God, blessed be He).

[ii]This refers to Rabbi Joseph Karo (1488-1575), author of the Shulchan Aruch (the authoritative code of Jewish law). The honorific 'zatzal' means 'may the memory of the righteous be a blessing.'

[iii]This is a kabbalistic concept connecting human physicality to the primordial serpent (nachash) from the Garden of Eden narrative, suggesting that material existence itself is inherently connected to impurity and temptation.

[iv]This is a quote from Ecclesiastes 4:5, 'The fool folds his hands and consumes his own flesh,' reinterpreted here in a mystical context to refer to how materialistic desires harm the body but not the soul.

בגן עדן ומזדווגים שם נפש הזכר ונפש הנקבה זמן מה ומזווגם נוצר להם כתנות אור. ועל זווג זה ראשון בג״ע אמרו בגמרא ארבעים יום קודם יצירת הולד בת קול יוצאת וכו׳. עד בואה לעה״ז. ואמרו שהם כדוגמת כתנות אור שעתיד להיות לה בעה״ז ואם זוכה לחזור שם מתלבשת עוד בהם בתוספת עילוי כי עתה הרויחה אותם ונוטלת ומתלבשת משלה באורות ההם קודם עלותה לג״ע עליון. והם דוגמת כתנות אור שהיו לאדם וחוה שם. ועל הכונה הזאת אשרי המקבל עליו דין שמים באהבה כי כאשר ייסר איש את בנו אלהינו מיסרנו. ואמרו במדבר רבה פ״ט על פסוק אחת לאחת למצא חשבון אדם נכשל בעבירה שחייבין עליה מיתה בידי שמים מת שורו אבדה תרנגולתו נשברה צלוחיתו נכשל באצבעו החשבון מתמצה. שכמו שהאב הרודה את בנו ורב תלמידו מכוין להכות ולחבוט חביטו על אותו כח היצה״ר המתעהו ולכן אמרו במדרש רבה פרק ז׳ חבוט חביטך דהיא טבא בקילטא וכתיב יסר בנך ויניחך ויתן מעדנים לנפשך כדוגמא זאת הם היסורין הבאים מאת פני השם על בשר אדם ועל עור הנחש כנזכר. ואמרו בב״ר פ׳ מ׳ על פ׳ טרף נתן ליראיו טירוף נתן ליראיו בעה״ז. אבל לעה״ב יזכור לעולם בריתו. ובפ׳ צ״ב

Palace of the Sapphire Brick,[3] when it tarried there in the Garden of Eden. There, the male soul and the female soul unite[1] for a time, and from their union, garments of light are formed for them.

Concerning this first union in the Garden of Eden, they said in the Talmud: "Forty days before the formation of the fetus, a heavenly voice proclaims,"[2] etc., until it comes to this world. And they said that these are like the garments of light that the soul will have in the future in this world. If one merits to return there, the soul is further clothed in them with additional elevation, for now it has earned them and takes and clothes itself with its own in those lights before ascending to the upper Garden of Eden. These are like the garments of light that Adam and Eve had there.

With this intention, fortunate is the one who accepts the judgment of Heaven with love, for "as a man disciplines his son, the LORD our God disciplines us."[3] They said in Bamidbar Rabbah, chapter 9, on the verse "one by one to find the account":[4] If a person stumbles in a transgression for which they are liable to death by the hand of Heaven, his ox dies, his chicken is lost, his flask breaks, or he injures his finger—the account is settled. Just as a father who disciplines his son or a teacher his student intends to strike and beat his beaten one against the power of the evil inclination that leads him astray, therefore they said in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 7: "Beat your beating that is good in the basket," and it is written: "Discipline your son and he will give you rest, and give delights to your soul." Similarly, these are the sufferings that come from before the LORD upon the flesh of man and upon the skin of the serpent, as mentioned.

They said in Bereshit Rabbah, chapter 40, on the verse "He has given food to those who fear Him":

[2]Heichal Livnat HaSapir is a celestial realm mentioned in Exodus 24:10 and elaborated upon in mystical texts. In Kabbalah, it represents a high spiritual domain where souls reside before incarnation.

[3]This reflects the kabbalistic concept that souls have masculine and feminine aspects that unite before incarnation, with this union determining the nature of the garments of light that will protect the soul.

[4]This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Sotah 2a) that forty days before conception, a heavenly voice proclaims who will marry whom, connecting prenatal soul destiny with the soul's previous spiritual status.

[5]This reference to Deuteronomy 8:5 establishes the theological framework for understanding suffering as divine discipline motivated by love rather than punishment motivated by anger.

[6]This is a reference to Ecclesiastes 7:27, reinterpreted in midrashic literature to explain how seemingly minor misfortunes can serve as substitutes for more severe divine judgments.

אמר רבי אלכסנדראי אין לך אדם בלא יסורין אשריו לאדם שיסורין באים עליו. ובויקרא רבה פ׳ ל״ב אמר כי הצדיקים ביציאתם מג״ע ורואים הרשעים בגיהנם לותנים שבח והודאה להקב״ה על היסורין שהביא עליהם בעה״ז הה״ד אודך ה׳ כי אנפת בי. ומדת הגבורה נקראת מהללאל בסוד עשר דורות שמאדם עד נח[i] שרומזים לעשר ספירות שבחכמה כפי דרך דורשי רזין דאורייתא ומדת הגבורה באה במדת מהללאל כי על ידה יהלל אדם להקב״ה כשהוא מתיסר ממנה ונצול א״כ היא גורמת מהלל החסד. עוד היסורים לאדם הם צורך גבוה דכל זמן שהרשעים פוגמים והקב״ה סובל הפגם הספירות מקבלות פגם ח״ו ובפרט מקום מוצא נשמת החוטא אמנם כאשר הדינים יושפעו מהספירות למטה במלכות הספירות מתוקנות כי משפיעות הפגם והדין מהם למדת המלכות והיא נוטלת כל אותם הדינים ונפרדת למטה ופועלת על ידי החצונים הדינים הם ברשעים. והיינו וינחם ה׳ זהו היחוד בספירות העליונות. ובמה עם ויתעצב אל לבו ירצה משפיע העצבון והפגם מהרשעים אל לבו למטה במלכות לפעול אותם. ואפי׳ בצדיק אחד הגון די לקדושה והספירות העליונות סומכות עליו כי צדיק יסוד

He has given affliction to those who fear Him in this world, but in the World to Come, "He will forever remember His covenant." And in chapter 92, Rabbi Alexandri said: "There is no person without sufferings; fortunate is the person upon whom sufferings come." And in Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 32, it says that the righteous, upon their departure from the Garden of Eden, seeing the wicked in Gehenna, give praise and thanks to the Holy One, blessed be He, for the sufferings He brought upon them in this world, as it is written: "I will thank You, LORD, for You were angry with me."[1]

The attribute of Gevurah is called "Mahalalel" in the secret of the ten generations from Adam to Noah, which allude to the ten sefirot within Wisdom, according to the way of those who seek the secrets of the Torah. The attribute of Gevurah comes with the attribute of Mahalalel,[2] for through it a person praises the Holy One, blessed be He, when he is disciplined by it and saved; thus, it causes the praise of Chesed.

Furthermore, sufferings for a person serve a higher purpose, for as long as the wicked cause damage and the Holy One, blessed be He, bears the damage, the sefirot receive damage, God forbid, especially the place where the soul of the sinner originates. However, when judgments flow from the sefirot down to Malkhut, the sefirot are rectified, for they channel the damage and judgment from them to the attribute of Malkhut, which takes all those judgments, separates below, and through the external forces, applies those judgments to the wicked. This is the meaning of "and the LORD was comforted"[3]—this is the unification in the supernal sefirot. And with what? With "and He was grieved in His heart"—meaning He channeled the grief

[1]This quote from Isaiah 12:1 is interpreted to mean that the righteous will ultimately recognize divine punishment as beneficial, providing retrospective understanding of suffering's spiritual purpose.

[2]The author creates an innovative connection between the biblical figure Mahalalel (whose name contains the root 'to praise') and the sefirah of Gevurah (divine judgment/strength), suggesting that judgment ultimately leads to praise of God's mercy.

[3]The author reinterprets Genesis 6:6 through a kabbalistic lens, understanding divine emotional language as describing cosmic processes of judgment flowing through the sefirot rather than actual divine emotions.

[i]The author draws a connection between Mahalalel (one of the antediluvian patriarchs listed in Genesis) and the sefirah of Gevurah (divine strength/judgment), seeing the ten generations from Adam to Noah as corresponding to the ten sefirot.

עולם[ii] ואומר הקב״ה די לי בזה
שבראתי בעולמי כלום בראתיו
אלא באדם אחד. ולכן על ידי
נח כתיב זה ינחמנו ועל ידו היה
היחוד באדם העליון ובארץ
התחתונה. ועליו נאמר וינחם
ה׳ כי עשה את האדם בארץ.
ומצד הפנים תחתונים שבמדת
מלכות שאחוזים בהם שאר בני
הדור כתיב ויתעצב אל לבו פי׳
השפיע הדינים למטה עליהם ונח
מצא חן היינו יסוד המיחד ולכן
נצטייר במדה ההיא בסוד צדיק
תמים[i] ונכנס אל התיבה וקיים
העולם. ע״כ זאת ישיב אל לבו
האדם החולה ויכוין שיהיה גופו
מזבח כפרה לצורך גבוה. [ii]

and damage from the wicked to His heart below in Malkhut to execute them.

Even with one suitable righteous person, it is sufficient for holiness, and the upper sefirot rely upon him, for "the righteous one is the foundation of the world." And the Holy One, blessed be He, says: "It is enough for Me that I created in My world; did I create it except for one person?" Therefore, concerning Noah it is written: "This one will comfort us," and through him was the unification in the supernal Man and in the lower earth. And of him it is said: "And the LORD was comforted that He had made man on the earth." And from the aspect of the lower faces in the attribute of Malkhut, to which the rest of the generation cling, it is written: "And He was grieved in His heart"—meaning He channeled judgments down upon them. "And Noah found favor"—this refers to the foundation that unifies, and therefore he was formed in that attribute in the secret of "a righteous, perfect man," and he entered the ark and sustained the world.

Therefore, the sick person should take this to heart and intend that his body be an altar of atonement for a higher purpose.

ואמרו בירושלמי דפאה
פ״ק[iii] שאפי׳ לא עשה תשובה

And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah, first chapter, that even if one did not repent

[i] This is a quote from Proverbs 10:25, 'The righteous is the foundation of the world,' which in Kabbalah is connected to the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation), representing the channel through which divine energy flows into the world.

[ii] The author interprets Noah's 'finding favor' as a reference to his connection with the sefirah of Yesod, which serves as a unifying principle, explaining why Noah is described as a 'righteous, perfect man' who could sustain the world.

[iii] Cf. Psalms 91:15 — The citation of 'I am with him in distress' (from Psalms 91:15) serves as a theological foundation for prayer during illness, suggesting that God's presence is especially near to those who suffer. | Cf. Psalms 32:6 — The phrase 'For this shall every pious one pray at a time of finding' refers to prayer at opportune moments, particularly during illness when the soul is more receptive to spiritual elevation. | Cf. Psalms 4:5 — The reference to 'Speak in your hearts upon your beds' supports the idea that even silent meditation or inner prayer has spiritual efficacy, especially for those too weak to vocalize. | Cf. Temple Incense Ritual — The recommendation to recite the passages about the Temple incense reflects the kabbalistic belief that this ritual has special power to alleviate illness and guide the soul's transition, serving as a spiritual substitute for the actual Temple service. | Cf. Bereshit Rabbah 9 — The midrashic interpretation of 'one by one to find the account' establishes the principle of measure-for-measure divine justice, where even small sufferings can substitute for major punishments. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah 32 — This reference supports the work's central thesis that suffering should be viewed positively as spiritual purification, so much so that even after death, souls recognize the value of their earthly trials. | Cf. Genesis 6:6 — The kabbalistic interpretation of 'the LORD was comforted' and 'He was grieved in His heart' transforms these phrases into a cosmic description of how divine judgment flows through the sefirot to affect the material world.

[i] The Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah (Corner of the Field), is cited to support the idea that suffering has purifying power even without formal repentance.

ומת ביסורין היסורין ממרקין
ובירושלמי דיומא פרק ז׳, אין
יום הכפורים מכפר בלא תשובה,
145 המיתה מכפרת בלא תשובה,[i] תני
יום מיתה כיום תשובה. ואמרו
חכמים שכל בריאת עולמות
המלאכים והגלגלים היה בשביל
עולם השפל ועיקר בריאת עולם
150 היה להשלים הנשמות שלמעלה
משלש עולמות ע״י רדתן על
הארץ שיהנו מטוב הגנוז להם
בשכר פעולתם ולא בתורת חסד
כבראשונה. ועוד שאר מעלות
155 הרבה להם בהשלמת פעולתן
ויכולים להתעלות למעלה
ממקום מוצאו וזהו בורא השמים
ונוטיהם[ii] וגו׳ נותן נשמה לעם
עליה וגו׳. ואמרו מיום שנברא
160 העולם נתאוה הקב״ה שיהיה לו
דירה בתחתונים שהוא ע״י נשמות
הצדיקים למטה בעה״ז. וא״כ
אשרי המשים אשם נפשו[iii] על
מה שחסר ממלאכתו אשר למענו
165 שולח פה. ואם ראשו ואבריו
ועורקיו וגידיו אשר הם שקתות

and died with sufferings, the sufferings purify him.[A] And in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Yoma, seventh chapter: "Yom Kippur does not atone without repentance, but death atones without repentance." It was taught: "The day of death is like the day of repentance." 150R

The Sages said that the entire creation of the worlds, angels, and celestial spheres was for the sake of this lower world. The primary purpose of creating the world was to perfect the souls that are above the three worlds[1] through their descent to earth, so that they might enjoy the goodness stored away for them as reward for their deeds, not merely as an act of kindness as it was originally.[2] There are many other advantages for them in completing their mission, as they can elevate themselves above their point of origin. This is the meaning of "Creator of the heavens and stretches them out...[A] giving a soul to the people upon it." 155R 160R 165R

They also said that from the day the world was created, the Holy One, blessed be He, desired to have a dwelling in the lower realms,[3] which is accomplished through the souls of the righteous below in this world. Therefore, fortunate is one who offers his soul as a guilt-offering[B] for what is lacking in his 170R

[A] Or: "the sufferings polish away [his sins]" — The Hebrew term 'ממרקין' has connotations of polishing or scouring rather than simple purification, suggesting a more active process of refinement. This alternate better captures the metallurgical metaphor implied in the original.

[B] Or: "And this is what is meant by "Creator of the heavens and their expanses..."" — This alternate translation of 'נוטיהם' as 'their expanses' rather than 'stretches them out' might better reflect the nominal form in the Hebrew, though both are acceptable translations of this biblical phrase.

[A] Or: "places his soul as a guilt-offering" — The Hebrew verb 'משים' literally means 'places' or

[1] This refers to the Kabbalistic concept that souls originate in a realm above the three worlds of Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action), and must descend through these worlds to achieve their ultimate perfection.

[2] This suggests a shift in the divine economy of reward—while initially souls might have received divine goodness as a pure gift (חסד/chesed), after descending to earth they earn it through their own actions, which has greater spiritual value.

[3] This is a central concept in Jewish mystical thought, that God desires to dwell specifically in the physical world through human service, despite (or perhaps because of) its lowliness and distance from divinity.

[i] This establishes a theological hierarchy where death has greater atoning power than even Yom Kippur, as it can provide atonement without the prerequisite of repentance.

[iii] A partial citation of Isaiah 42:5: "Thus says God the LORD, Who created the heavens and stretched them out, Who spread out the earth and its offspring, Who gives breath to the people on it and spirit to those who walk in it."

[iv] This phrase alludes to the biblical concept of "asham" (guilt offering) from Leviticus, but applies it metaphorically to one's soul and suffering. This spiritual reframing of physical suffering as a sacrificial offering is central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness and death.

הגוף[iv] כבדים עליו בחליו ישים אשם נפשו [i]

work, for which purpose he was sent here. And if his head, limbs, arteries, and sinews—which are the channels of the body[1]—feel heavy upon him in his illness, he should offer his soul as a guilt-offering.

וידע כי זה יהיה תקון גדול לצנורות ההשפעה מגולות עליונות וגולות תחתיות אשר קלקל ושבר בהעוותו בחטא עון ופשע בשלשה חלקי נפשו רוחו ונשמתו[ii] כי הריק מים חיים היורדים לגן אל האשפה דירה סרוחה[iii] ובזה יהיה גופו מזבח כפרה לנפשו ולתקון העולמות העליונים ויקיים בעצמו אדם כי יקריב מכם קרבן לה׳. וכפי בחינת החולי המתגבר עליו כן יפשפש במעשיו כי ודאי

And let him understand that this will be a great correction for the channels of divine influence from the supernal spheres and the lower spheres, which he damaged and broke through his perversion with sin, iniquity, and transgression[2] in the three parts of his soul, spirit, and higher soul. For he diverted the living waters that descend to the garden into a garbage heap,[3] a putrid dwelling. Through this, his body will become an altar of atonement for his soul and for the rectification of the upper worlds, and he will fulfill within himself "When a man among you brings an offering to the LORD."[A] According to the nature of the illness overtaking him,[4] so should

'puts,' and while 'offers' captures the sacrificial connotation well, 'places' more directly translates the term and maintains the physical imagery of placement present in the original.

[B]Or: "When any of you brings an offering to the LORD" — This is the opening verse of Leviticus 1:2, and this alternate translation more closely matches standard English Bible translations while preserving the same meaning.

[1]The Hebrew term 'שקתות' (shkatot) literally means 'troughs' or 'watering places,' emphasizing the body's role as a vessel for containing and directing life force, similar to how irrigation channels direct water.

[2]The Hebrew uses three distinct terms for wrongdoing (חטא, עון, פשע) which in Jewish tradition represent three levels of sin: unintentional errors, deliberate sins, and rebellious acts. This triplet appears frequently in liturgical confessions.

[3]This metaphor is central to kabbalistic understanding of sin: divine energy ('living waters') that should flow to sacred realms is misdirected through sin to unholy domains, strengthening forces of impurity.

[1]The text establishes a system where physical symptoms serve as diagnostic tools for spiritual ailments—a kind of spiritual pathology where bodily illness reveals the state of the soul.

[i]Literally "troughs of the body," referring to the channels through which vital fluids flow. In Kabbalistic thought, these correspond to the channels of divine flow in higher worlds that can become blocked or burdened through sin.

[ii]Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah — This reference to the Jerusalem Talmud provides a rabbinic foundation for the theological claim that suffering purifies sins even without formal repentance, establishing a framework where physical illness serves as spiritual atonement. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Yoma — This reference contrasts Yom Kippur's atonement (which requires repentance) with death's atonement (which can occur without repentance), suggesting that death has greater atoning power than even the holiest day of the Jewish calendar. | Cf. Isaiah 42:5 — The partial quote 'Creator of the heavens and stretches them out... giving a soul to the people upon it' comes from Isaiah 42:5, using prophetic authority to support the idea that souls are given to humanity for a divine purpose. | Cf. Isaiah 53:10 — The phrase 'offers his soul as a guilt-offering' alludes to Isaiah 53:10, which describes the suffering servant who 'makes himself an offering for guilt.' This connects personal suffering to sacrificial atonement in Temple theology.

[iii]The text references the three-part division of the soul in Kabbalah: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). These correspond to three levels of consciousness and three types of sins.

[iv]This metaphor depicts sin as diverting divine flow ('living waters') from its proper destination (the garden, symbolizing holy realms) to impure places (garbage heap). In Kabbalistic thought, sin redirects divine energy to the 'Other Side' (sitra achra).

ימצא פגמו כפי סיבת חליו
כי מדה כנגד מדה לא בטלה.
וידוע כי דין ארבע מיתות לא
בטלו.[i] כובד ראשו יהיה יען
כי לא היה קל להשליב רצון
מלכו ואלהיו וכנגד מה שלא
הבין בשכלו מה לעשות נחת
רוח ליוצרו והכביד אזניו וחשע
עיניו מלמאום ברע ולבחור
בטוב. פיו המואס כל מאכל
כנגד שלא עשה מטעמים לקונו
ועל כי מאס בתורת ה׳ שלא
להגות בה יומם ולילה וכבר
ידענו כי חיים הם למוצאיהם
ודרשי רבותינו ז״ל למוצאיהם
בפה. לשונו הגובר עליה הליחות
גרמה שהצבור בת לשון הנחש
באמרי פיו. ושניו שלא טחנו מן
לצדיקים שהם נגד כ״ה שחקים
וכן הם ל״ב ט״ז למעלה וט״ז
למטה[ii] כמי שנצח היד אחד
נוטה למעלה לצד החסד ואחד
למטה לצד הדין והם כלולים
בעצמם מעשר ומכללות שש
ספירות אחרות שהם סוד שעור
קומה ובכוונת האכילה לשמה
ולקרבן לה׳ ובענג שבתות וימים
טובים מכינים שפע לצדיק
וצדק.[iii] והוא כי חריץ שניו
נגד יראי ה׳ ולעס לעיסות
אסורות ונהנה בלא ברכה

he examine his deeds, for he will certainly find his flaw corresponding to the cause of his illness, since the principle of measure for measure has not ceased. And it is known that the four death penalties of the court have not been abolished.[1]

The heaviness of his head is because he was not quick to fulfill the will of his King and God, and because he did not understand with his intellect how to bring satisfaction to his Creator, and he hardened his ears and closed his eyes from rejecting evil and choosing good. His mouth that now rejects all food corresponds to his failure to prepare delicacies for his Creator and because he rejected the Torah of the LORD by not meditating on it day and night. We already know that "they are life to those who find them," and our Sages of blessed memory interpreted "to those who find them" as "to those who express them with the mouth." His tongue, now overwhelmed with phlegm, caused him to join the company of the serpent's tongue with the words of his mouth. His teeth that did not grind food for the righteous,[A] which correspond to the twenty-five heavens[B]—and there are thirty-two of them, sixteen above and sixteen below, like one who triumphs with one hand extending upward toward kindness and one downward toward judgment. They are included within themselves from ten and from the entirety of six other sefirot, which are the secret of the divine structure. Through proper intention in eating for the sake of Heaven and as an offering to the LORD, and through the delight of Sabbaths and festivals, one prepares abundance

[A] Or: "that did not grind manna for the righteous" — The Hebrew 'man' (מן) specifically refers to the biblical manna, which in kabbalistic thought symbolizes spiritual sustenance. This more specific translation preserves the mystical connotation.

[B] Or: "twenty-five firmaments" — The Hebrew 'shchakim' is often translated as 'firmaments' in kabbalistic contexts, which might be more precise for this mystical discussion of cosmic structures.

[1] This refers to the Talmudic concept that although the Sanhedrin no longer carries out executions, the four biblical death penalties (stoning, burning, beheading, and strangulation) continue to occur through natural causes as divine justice.

[i] This refers to the four capital punishments of the ancient Sanhedrin court (stoning, burning, beheading, and strangulation). Though no longer carried out literally after the Temple's destruction, the Talmud states that their spiritual counterparts continue through natural causes of death.

[ii] This refers to Kabbalistic concepts of cosmic structure. The 32 teeth correspond to the 32 paths of wisdom in Sefer Yetzirah (formed by the 22 Hebrew letters and 10 sefirot), divided into upper and lower realms.

[i] In Kabbalistic terminology, 'Tzaddik' (Righteous One) refers to the sefirah of Yesod, and 'Tzedek' (Righteousness) refers to Malkhut. This describes how proper eating channels divine abundance to these lower sefirot.

לכן עתה יכהו שניו בדברים
מדים ויחרקו לצערו נגד מה
שנהנה באסור. זרועותיו שפשטו
בנשך ותרבית לקח בהרמת יד
ונמנעו מעשות בהם מצות וקפץ
ידיו מאחיו האביון עתה הם
כבדים עליו ותשש כחם כנקבה
המקבלת ואינה משפעת. לב
חורש מחשבות און והקשה עצמו
כאבן לבלתי שמוע אל התורה
והמצוה. עתה לבו כים יהמה
בסערות חמה. אבריו הפנימיים
שכל אחד לדרכו פנה. כבד
כעס הכסילים ומרה זרקה בו
טפה. מעיו נהנו מן הגזל. ריאה
ששאבה משקים אסורים. עתה
כלם תוהים ובוהים והציקתהו
רוח בטנו. שינתו לא ערבה
לו על כי לא נדד שינה מעיניו
לעסוק בתורה ותפלה עם
הצבור. ואבריו כמעט בטלים
ממלאכתם ומאכילים אותם
דברים מרים וקשים כגידים
המסעדים אותם במיחושים וקיא.
ולחמו במעיו נהפך מרורת
פתנים בקרבו ועליו תשתפך
נפשו. ומעיו רותחו ולא דמו.
גופו שמרק עצמו לדבר עברה
יוכח במכאוב על משכבו. בשרו
שנהנה מתענוגי העולם יכל
בשרו מרואי. עצמותיו שעונותיו
חקוקים עליהם שופו עצמותיו
לא רואו ועצמו חרה מני חורב.
עורו שלבש כלאים עתה הוא
ניחר מעליו. ירכותיו שהתחילו
בעבירות תחלה עתה ירופפו
וחתחתים בהן. ברכיו דשלהי
מלקום לשמוע את דבר ה׳
ולענות קדיש וקדושה וברכו
עתה ארכובותיה דא לדא נקשן.
רגליו הממהרות לרוץ לרעה
ונמנעות מללכת לדברי מצוה

for the Righteous One and Righteousness.[C] The gap of his teeth opposed those who fear the LORD; he chewed forbidden foods and enjoyed them without a blessing. Therefore, now his teeth are struck with bitter things and they gnash in his pain, corresponding to what he enjoyed in a forbidden manner. 225R

His arms that were extended in usury and excessive interest, raised in defiance, and refrained from performing commandments with them, and closed his hands from his needy brother, are now heavy upon him, and their strength is weakened like a female who receives but does not influence.[1] His heart that devised iniquitous thoughts and hardened itself like stone, refusing to listen to the Torah and commandment, now roars like the sea in stormy wrath. His inner organs, each one turning to its own way—the liver, the anger of fools, and the gall bladder that cast its drop into it; his intestines that enjoyed stolen goods; the lungs that drew in forbidden drinks—now they are all confused and perplexed, and the spirit of his belly afflicts him. His sleep is not sweet to him because he did not banish sleep from his eyes to engage in Torah and prayer with the congregation. His limbs are almost idle from their work, and they are fed bitter and hard things like sinews that support them with pains and vomit. His food in his bowels is turned to venom of serpents within him, and his soul pours itself out over it. His bowels boil and are not silent. His body that cleansed itself for sinful matters is reproved with pain on his bed. His flesh that enjoyed worldly pleasures—his flesh wastes away from appearance. His bones, upon which his iniquities are engraved—his bones are crushed and not seen, and his substance is dried up from heat. His skin that wore forbidden mixtures is now scorched from upon him. His thighs that began with transgressions first now tremble, and there is terror in them. His knees that were slow to rise to hear the word of the LORD and to respond to Kaddish, Kedusha, and Barchu, now knock one against the other. His feet that hastened to run to evil and refrained from walking toward matters of commandment and from standing in 230R 235R 240R 245R 250R 255R 260R

[A] Or: "Yesod and Malkhut" — In Kabbalistic terminology, 'Tzaddik' (Righteous One) refers to the sefirah of Yesod, and 'Tzedek' (Righteousness) refers to Malkhut. This technical translation would be more appropriate for readers familiar with Kabbalah.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of masculine and feminine spiritual energies, where the masculine principle actively gives while the feminine receives. Here, illness has reversed the proper function of the arms, which should be 'masculine' in giving charity.

ומלעמוד בסוד ישרים ועדה עתה הושמו בסוד רגליו והציקתהו רוח בטנו. עד כי יעתר אל אלוה וירצהו ויחשוך נפשו מני שחת:[i][ii]

the council of the upright and the congregation, are now set in the secret of his feet, and the spirit of his belly afflicts him—until he pleads with God who will accept him,[1] and He will spare his soul from the pit.

פרק כ״א

Chapter 21

עוד יכוין לתקון עון בטול תורה ועון שיחה בטלה ושבועת שוא ושקר וקללות וחרופים ולשון הרע וכדומה בצער הצמא והחרחור המתהוה לו מכח דין אשא דגרמי. ואש המתגבר בתוכו יכוין כי הוא אש אוכלה אש אשר הקדיח בעונותיו כדברי הנביא על העושים עברות אחר שחשבו לעשותם מוציאים מחשבתם הרעה מן הכח אל הפועל המכריז ואומר תהרו חשש תלדו קש רוחכם שהיא נשמה אש תאכלכם.[iii] ע״ד ותמוגנו ביד עונינו.[iv] ואמרו בירושלמי דשבת פרק י״ד והסיר ה׳ ממך כל חולי זו שריפה

He should also direct his intention toward rectifying the sin of neglecting Torah study, engaging in idle talk, taking false or vain oaths, uttering curses and insults, speaking evil speech, and similar transgressions through the suffering of thirst and the burning sensation arising from the judgment of the fire of the bones.[2] Regarding the fire intensifying within him, he should understand that it is a consuming fire, a fire which he ignited through his sins, as the prophet says concerning those who commit transgressions: after contemplating these acts, they bring their evil thoughts from potential to actual, which proclaims and declares, "You conceive chaff, you give birth to straw, your spirit (which is the soul)—fire will consume you." As it is written, "And we melt away in the hand of our iniquities." And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Shabbat Chapter 14, on the verse

[1]The passage ends with hope for recovery through sincere prayer and divine mercy, suggesting that the detailed suffering described is ultimately restorative rather than punitive.

[2]The Hebrew term "asha d'garmi" is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the spiritual fire that consumes the bones, associated with both fever and divine judgment. It appears in several passages in the Zohar.

[i]This final phrase, drawn from Job 33:24, concludes on a note of hope, suggesting that despite the detailed suffering described, sincere prayer and repentance can still save one from the pit (spiritual destruction).

[ii]Cf. Zohar — The passage draws heavily on Zoharic concepts that physical suffering corresponds to spiritual flaws and serves as atonement. The detailed correspondence between body parts and specific sins reflects the Zohar's approach to understanding illness as a spiritual process rather than merely physical. | Cf. Leviticus 1:2 — The quotation 'When a man among you brings an offering to the LORD' comes from the opening of Leviticus, establishing the concept that the suffering body becomes a sacrificial offering. This creates a theological framework where physical illness serves the same spiritual purpose as Temple sacrifices did. | Cf. Proverbs 4:22 — The phrase 'they are life to those who find them' is quoted from Proverbs, where it refers to words of Torah. The author uses the rabbinic interpretation of 'those who find them' (למוצאיהם) as 'those who express them with the mouth' to establish that verbal Torah study brings healing. | Cf. Daniel 5:6 — The phrase 'his knees knocked one against the other' (ארכובותיה דא לדא נקשן) echoes the description of Belshazzar's terror in Daniel. By using this scriptural language, the author connects the physical symptoms of illness to divine judgment, suggesting that bodily suffering reveals God's assessment of one's deeds.

[iii]This is a paraphrase of Isaiah 33:11, "You conceive chaff, you bring forth stubble, your breath is a fire that consumes you." The author uses this prophetic verse to show how sin ultimately turns against the sinner, consuming them from within.

[iv]This phrase references Psalms 64:7, "We melt away in the hand of our iniquities," emphasizing how sin itself becomes the agent of suffering rather than direct divine punishment.

ופירשו הקדחת שכל החולאים תלויים בה ופרונקא דמלאכא דמותא היא אשא דגרמי.[i] אם תסמר שערת בשרו וכדומה יכוין למיתוק קרירות הדין עליון שהגליד השפע היורד בעונותיו. ואיתא בפרשת נח דף ס״ח ע״ב כי דיני גיהנם הם אש ומים. ומלחמת ד׳ יסודותיו זה עם זה יחשב לכפרה על כי לא לחם מלחמת מצוה על אויבי נפשו כי התקוממו עליו להביא אל מסגר נפשו. בפרישתו מן היין יכוין לדחות מעליו כחות הדינים הבאים מכח יין המשכר ומדי שתייתו מים או תרופות לכבות אש הקודח בו יכוין למתק התעוררות הדינין הגוברים מהג׳ קליפות[ii] ומגדילים כח השלשה ראשי משחית. ובששותה מים יכוין לשתות מי החסד וזהו כונת השתיה שנאמרה למהר״רי קארו. ובתרופת המשלשלות יכוין לדחות כח המותרות והסיגים מעליו ומעל נשמתו לדחות אותם לנוקבא דתהומא רבא ובמצולות ים וצא יאמר להם מבאן ולהבא.[iii] ולבן אמרו כי מיתתן של צדיקים בחולי מעים מלבד פשוטן של דברים שמתים נקיים כמלאכים

"The Lord will remove from you all sickness"—this refers to burning, and they explained that fever is the root of all illnesses, and the messenger of the Angel of Death is the fire of the bones. If the hair of his flesh stands on end or similar reactions occur, he should direct his intention toward sweetening the coldness of the supernal judgment[1] that has frozen the divine flow descending to him because of his sins. And it is stated in Parshat Noah, page 68b, that the judgments of Gehenna are both fire and water. The battle of his four elements[2] against each other should be considered an atonement for not having fought the obligatory battle against the enemies of his soul who rose up against him to imprison his soul. In abstaining from wine, he should intend to repel the forces of judgment that come from the power of intoxicating wine, and whenever he drinks water or takes medicines to extinguish the burning fire within him, he should intend to sweeten the arousal of judgments that are empowered by the three husks[3] and that magnify the power of the three heads of destruction.[4] When drinking water, he should intend to drink the waters of loving-kindness, and this is the intention for drinking that was taught to Rabbi Joseph Karo. With purgative remedies, he should intend to expel the power of excess and impurities from himself and from his soul, to cast them into the great abyss and into the depths of the sea, and he should say to them, "Depart from here and onward." Therefore, they said that the death of the righteous is through intestinal illness,[5] beyond the simple ex-

[1] The concept of "sweetening judgments" (mituk ha-dinim) is a fundamental kabbalistic practice where harsh divine judgments are transformed into mercy through proper intention and spiritual action.

[2] This refers to the classical theory of four elements (earth, air, fire, water) that comprise the human body. In kabbalistic thought, illness occurs when these elements fall out of harmony, reflecting spiritual disharmony.

[3] In Lurianic Kabbalah, there are four "husks" or kelipot (negative spiritual forces), with three being entirely negative and one (kelipat nogah) being a mixture of good and evil. The author refers here to the three entirely negative husks.

[4] This likely refers to the kabbalistic concept of the three "heads" or primary manifestations of the negative spiritual forces: af (anger), chemah (wrath), and mashchit (destruction).

[1] This reflects a talmudic teaching (Bava Metzia 84b) that righteous individuals often die from intestinal diseases, which was understood as a purifying death that cleanses any minor sins.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase identifies "the fire of the bones" as the messenger or agent of the Angel of Death, explaining fever as the primary manifestation of deadly illness.

[iv] The "three husks" (shalosh kelipot) refers to the three entirely negative spiritual forces in Lurianic Kabbalah, as opposed to kelipat nogah which contains a mixture of good and evil.

[i] This phrase alludes to ritual banishment formulas used in exorcisms, suggesting that the elimination of waste from the body through purgatives should be understood as a spiritual exorcism of impure forces.

ובמיחושים וכאבים כבר אמור שיכוין לתקון עונות המחשבה והרהורים רעים ודעות כוזבות ח״ו. וכן על זה הדרך יחשוב דרכו בכל המאורעות הבאות עליו ויגול על ה׳ דרכו וה׳ הוא הטוב בעיניו יעשה. [i]

planation that they die pure like angels. And regarding pains and aches, it has already been stated that he should direct his intention toward rectifying the sins of improper thoughts, evil contemplations, and false beliefs, God forbid. In this manner, he should consider his ways in all events that befall him, and commit his way unto the Lord, and the Lord will do what is good in His eyes.

אמרו במדרש רבה פ״ט תרעא דלא פתיח למצותא פתיח לאסיא וכן הכתוב אומר והיה אם שמוע וגו׳ כל המחלה וגו׳. [ii] ועל דרך זה ישמע חכם ויוסף לקח מדעתו בהרבה פרטים כפי העת והחולי והמשתרג עליו. ואמרו בזהר שבחומא אדם באבר מאבריו ישאר אותו אבר טמא. וטוב לא יהיה לרשע באבר ההוא עד יענש בו והביא זה בעל שרש ישי ועד דו פתח ועד דו טרד רחמוהי קריבין: עיין בתקון ס״ט דף קי״ו מוצא הקדחת ומוצא השחפת וסוד הגברת כל אחד מארבע ליחות על האדם: עוד מזה שם בדף ק״פ ע״ב ובתקון כ״א דף נ״ז ע״א אמר כי המתקרבים ביסורין לגבי קב״ה וסבלין כמה מכתשין דדא

They said in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 9: "A gate that is not open for fulfilling commandments is open for the physician." And thus Scripture says, "And it shall be, if you diligently hearken..." [Exodus 15:26] "all the diseases..." And in this manner, let the wise listen and increase knowledge on his own[A] in many particulars according to the time, the illness, and what afflicts him.[B] And they said in the Zohar that when a person sins with one of his limbs, that limb remains impure. And there will be no good for the wicked in that limb until he is punished through it. This was cited by the author of Shoresh Yishai: "Until he opens, and until he is driven away, his mercies are near." See in Tikkun 69, page 116, the origin of fever, the origin of consumption, and the secret of the dominance of each of the four humors over a person. More about this appears there on page 180b, and in Tikkun 21, page 57a, where it says that those who draw near to the Holy One, blessed be He, through sufferings, and endure many afflictions—this

[A] Or: "And following this approach, the wise person will listen and add understanding from his own insight" — This alternate translation better captures the idiomatic nature of the Hebrew expression, emphasizing that the wise person should not just gain knowledge but actively apply personal insight to the general principles being discussed.

[B] Or: "and what entangles him" — The Hebrew root ג-ר-ש carries the connotation of intertwining or entangling. This alternate translation more directly reflects the metaphorical image of illness as something that ensnares or entangles the person.

[ii] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Shabbat Chapter 14 — The author uses this talmudic source to explain physical symptoms as manifestations of spiritual conditions, specifically connecting fever with divine judgment. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Noah, 68b — The author draws a parallel between the suffering of illness (involving both burning and chills) and the purification process of Gehenna, suggesting that physical suffering can serve as atonement in this world rather than the next. | Cf. Isaiah 33:11 — The author uses this prophetic imagery to illustrate how sins ultimately consume the sinner through physical illness, establishing illness as the natural consequence of sin rather than arbitrary punishment. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's teachings to Rabbi Joseph Karo — This reference shows how Ma'avar Yabok integrates both widely known kabbalistic concepts and more specialized teachings that may have been transmitted through particular lineages. | Cf. Psalms 37:5 — The author concludes with this biblical reference to emphasize that while one should engage in spiritual reflection and rectification during illness, ultimately one must surrender to divine will.

[iii] This is a reference to Exodus 15:26, where God promises the Israelites that if they follow His commandments, He will not bring upon them the diseases He brought upon Egypt. The text interprets this as indicating that illness comes when one fails to fulfill commandments.

שזיב להו ממיתה וממלאך המות:
ואילין דעובדיהון כבעירין
דחקלא דאכלין בלא צלותין
מיתתהון תהא כבעירין ושחיט
להו מלאך המות בסכין פגים.
ושאינם נזהרים בשחיטה סכין
מלאך המות להם היא אוגרת
ומסוכסכת עולה ויורד ויש להם
במיתתם שהיה דרסה חלדה
הגרמה עקור.[i] והתשובה רטייה
לכל נגע ומחלה: ובר״מ פרשת
פנחס דף רי״ט אמר למה מהירות
הדפק מורה מיתה. ובתקון כ״א
דבר שם ג״כ מדפיקת הדפק
ואמר שהוא מאזן שמאל של הלב
וזהו רוח צפונית שהיה מנשב
בכנור של דוד. וכל העורקים
ווירידי הגוף הדופקים מן הלב
הם דופקים וזה סוד אל אשר
יהיה שמה הרוח ללכת ילכו.
וכבד שהוא סמך מם דלית ביה
רוחא דקודשא לא דפקין ערקין
דיליה. זהו מהתקונים דף ל״ז
ול״ח: ובזהר בפרשות הנזכרים
ביאר כוונת הקזת דם מזרוע ימין
ומזרוע סמאל ומווירידי הראש:
עוד שם דף רכ״ז כתוב כי ד׳
מלאכים קדושים שולטים על ד׳
יסודות האדם ומרכבה חצונית
על ד׳ מרות לבנה סומקא ירוקה
שחורה:[ii] עוד מזה בדף רל״ב
ע״ב. עוד בתקון י״ח דף ל״ו
ע״א אמר כי מן הדפק נפיק רוח
סערה דאסעיר גופיה דבר נש
והוא מפרק הרים דאינון גרמין
דגופא ומשבר סלעים דאינון
צלעות דגופא והא דפיקו סליק
בגלגלין ונחית בימא דאינון עשר
כתרין תתאין ושם פירשו כתרין

saves them from death and from the Angel of Death. But those whose deeds are like the beasts of the field, who eat without prayers, their death will be like that of beasts, and the Angel of Death slaughters them with a defective knife.[A] And those who are not careful regarding ritual slaughter—the knife of the Angel of Death for them is jagged and rough, moving up and down, and they experience in their death the invalidating factors of slaughter: pressing, covering, tearing, and uprooting. But repentance is a balm for every plague and disease.

And in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas, page 219, he explains why rapid pulse indicates impending death. And in Tikkun 21, he also speaks about the pulse, saying that it is from the left side of the heart, and this is the north wind that used to blow in David's harp. And all the arteries and veins of the body that pulse from the heart—they pulse, and this is the secret of "wherever the spirit would go, they would go" [Ezekiel 1:12]. But the liver, which is the letter samekh-mem [forming the word "support"], which has no holy spirit in it, its veins do not pulse. This is from the Tikkunim, pages 37 and 38. And in the Zohar, in the sections mentioned, he explained the intention behind bloodletting from the right arm, from the arm of Samael, and from the veins of the head. Further, on page 227, it is written that four holy angels rule over the four elements of man, and an external chariot over the four humors: white, red, green, and black. More on this in page 232b. Further, in Tikkun 18, page 36a, he says that from the pulse emerges a storm wind that stirs up a person's body, and it breaks apart mountains, which are the bones of the body, and shatters rocks, which are the ribs of the body. And behold, the pulse rises in the celestial spheres and descends into the sea, which are the ten lower crowns. And there they explained that the lower crowns are husks to the ten sefirot. And see Parashat Vayechi, page

[A] Or: "flawed knife" — The Hebrew term 'pagim' can be translated as either 'defective' or 'flawed' in this context. Both convey the mystical concept of a spiritually imperfect tool used by the Angel of Death for those who die without spiritual preparation.

[i] These terms refer to the five invalidating factors in ritual slaughter (shechita): pressing (derasah), covering (chaladah), tearing (hagramat), uprooting (ikur), and delaying (shehiyah)—though the last is not mentioned here. The author is creating a spiritual parallel between improper ritual slaughter and the spiritual defects in an unprepared person's death.

[ii] This refers to the four humors in ancient and medieval medicine: phlegm (white), blood (red), yellow bile (green), and black bile (black). The author connects these physical humors to kabbalistic concepts of four angelic forces governing the body.

תחאין דאינון קליפין לעשר ספירות. ועיין פרשת ויחי דף רכ״ז למה הזיעה טובה לחולה כדאמרו רז״ל חמשה דברים יפים לחולה עטוש וזיעה ושינה וחלום וקרי.[i] רבנן דקסראי אמרי אף הילוך מעים כדרך כל הארץ. ויש שתי מיני זיעות אחת טובה ואחת רעה ח״ו. ואמר כי אפי׳ בכל זמנא דנפיל איניש בבי מרעיה[ii]

227, why sweating is good for the sick, as our Sages of blessed memory said: "Five things are beneficial for the sick: sneezing, sweating, sleeping, dreaming, and seminal emission." The rabbis of Caesarea said: "Also the normal functioning of the bowels." And there are two types of sweat, one good and one bad, God forbid. And he said that even in every instance when a person falls ill

ולא יכיל לצלאה נשמתא אעברת וסלקא מניה עד דדיינין ליה[iii] ודוחקא בגופא אשתכח בעת שדנין אותו ונשמתיה אסהידת בכל רעיונין דבר נש דעובדוהי כתיבין בספרא. ופירוש למה הרשעים מתרפאים. והרפואה מזומנת לחולים בבקר היא בפרשת בלק דף רמ״ג. ובפרשת ויחי דף רמ״ה ע״א אמר כי אבריו של אדם מתחזקים בשעת המיתה. ומוצא כל היסורין הם משוקין דסטרא אחרא דתמן אית רצין דנקראים רודפים. ברם צדיקי וחסידי לית להו מרעין מסטרא דא[iv] כן כתוב

When a person cannot pray, his soul departs and ascends from him until they judge him, and distress is found in the body at the time they judge him. His soul testifies to all the thoughts of the person, whose deeds are written in the book. The explanation of why the wicked recover from illness, and why healing is readily available to the sick in the morning, is found in Parashat Balak, page 243. And in Parashat Vayechi, page 245a, it states that a person's limbs strengthen at the time of death. The source of all suffering comes from the channels of the Other Side, where there are runners called "pursuers." However, the righteous and pious do not suffer illnesses from this source, as written in Parashat Pekudei, page 244. The sick person is judged by the judges of the second entrance in the third palace of holiness, and all

[i] This is a medical teaching from the Talmud (Berakhot 57b) listing five phenomena considered beneficial for the sick. The author integrates this medical knowledge into a kabbalistic framework, showing how Ma'avar Yabok bridges practical medical advice with mystical understanding.

[ii] Cf. Midrash Rabbah — The quoted midrash establishes a fundamental principle that illness serves as an opportunity for spiritual reflection when one has failed to engage in positive commandments. This creates a theological framework where physical ailments are not random but serve a spiritual purpose. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas — The reference to the Ra'aya Mehemna section of the Zohar provides mystical significance to physical symptoms like rapid pulse. This reflects the text's integration of medical knowledge with kabbalistic interpretations of bodily functions. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The references to various Tikkunim sections establish the kabbalistic understanding of illness as related to cosmic imbalances in the four elements/humors that constitute the human body. This provides the metaphysical foundation for the text's approach to healing. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:12 — The biblical quote about the spirit's movement is applied to explain the mystical understanding of the pulse, creating a correspondence between the divine chariot (merkavah) and human physiology. This reflects the text's worldview where biblical verses reveal hidden truths about physical functions. | Cf. Shoresh Yishai — This reference to an earlier kabbalistic work reinforces the author's point about the relationship between sin and physical ailments. By citing this authority, the author establishes his teaching within an established tradition of kabbalistic thought regarding illness.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar describes how the soul temporarily departs from a sick person who cannot pray, ascending until judgment is rendered, creating an opportunity for celestial intervention.

[i] This important distinction shows that the righteous do not suffer from illnesses originating from the 'Other Side' (negative spiritual forces), suggesting their ailments serve different, more elevated spiritual purposes.

בפ׳ פקודי דף רמ״ד. והחולה
נדון בדייני פתח השני שבהיכל
השלישי מהקדושה[i] וכל הגזירות
הם בהיכל זה חוץ מבני חיי
ומזוני ואור מצד מזרח מהיכל
הרביעי ממונה על הרפואה.
ואין לחולה לצמצם דמי רפואתו
כי אינו מתרפא עד שיוציא
כל סך הממון שנגזר עליו[ii] אם
לא נגזר עליו רק עונש נכסים
כך כתוב בסוף פרשת האזינו:
ואמרו בתקונים דשבעין עורקין
אית בכבדא לקבלא שבעין
ממנן. ושבעים תיבות שבמזמור
יענך ה׳ ביום צרה שנוהגים
לאומרו בראש תפלת החולים
הם כנגדם שהם צירים וחבלים
דכח הקדושה: ואמרו בתקון ע׳
שכל מצוה שורה על כל אבר ויש
להם שם ידוע וכל חיילין ומחנות
התלויות ממנה כלם מתאספים
לאותו אבר ושומרים אותו
מכל חולאים רעים: והממליך
קדוש ב״ה על כל אבריו כאלו
ממליכו בכל העולם שהאדם
הוא עולם קטן[iii] ושכרו לא נתן
רשות ליגלות שלא יעבוד על
מנת לקבל פרס: ואמרו בפרשת
האזינו דאית חולאים דרפואתן
על ידי צלותין ובעותין ומילי
דחסידותא ורופא א׳ היה מרפא
יותר בפיו ממה שהיה עושה
בידיו: ועל זה סיפר נפלאות
משכר רופא כזה: אבל הרופא
האמיתי היא השכי״נה שכן היא
בגימטריא רופ״א חנ״ם:[iv] ועל
ידי מרירות היסורין והרשעים
שמתמרמרים בתשובה ממתקים

decrees are issued in this palace, except for children, life, and sustenance. Light from the east side of the fourth palace is appointed over healing. A sick person should not stint on the cost of his treatment, for he will not recover until he spends the entire sum of money decreed for him, unless only a financial penalty was decreed for him, as written at the end of Parashat Ha'azinu. 140R 145R

It is stated in the Tikkunim that there are seventy veins in the liver corresponding to seventy celestial appointees. The seventy words in the psalm "May the Lord answer you in the day of trouble" (Psalm 20), which is customarily recited at the beginning of prayers for the sick, correspond to these veins, which are the contractions and pains of the power of holiness. It is stated in the 70th Tikkun that every commandment rests upon each limb, and they have a known name, and all the hosts and camps dependent upon it all gather to that limb and protect it from all evil diseases. One who crowns the Holy One, blessed be He, over all his limbs is as if he crowned Him over the entire world, for man is a microcosm, and his reward has not been permitted to be revealed so that he should not serve in order to receive a reward. 150R 155R 160R

It is stated in Parashat Ha'azinu that there are illnesses whose healing comes through prayers, supplications, and acts of piety, and one physician was healing more with his mouth than with his hands. Concerning this, wonders were told about the reward of such a physician. But the true physician is the Divine Presence, as it equals in gematria "physician without cost." Through the bitterness of suffering and the wicked who become bitter in repentance, they sweeten the name of Strength (Gevurah) and unify it above, and therefore they transform the attribute of judgment into the attribute of mercy, and sweeten the powers of Strength. All those beings that were darkened are washed in the waters of the 165R 170R 175R

[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic structure of the heavenly courts, specifically identifying which celestial tribunal handles illness cases—the judges of the second entrance in the third palace of holiness.

[iii] This unusual instruction reveals a mystical economic view of healing: recovery requires spending exactly the amount decreed in heaven, suggesting one should not be frugal with medical expenses.

[iv] This expresses the microcosm-macrocosm principle central to Jewish mysticism: that the human body parallels the entire cosmos, making spiritual sovereignty over one's body equivalent to divine sovereignty over the universe.

[i] This presents a gematria (numerical equivalence) showing that 'Shekhinah' (Divine Presence) equals 'physician without cost' (rofeh chinam), establishing the Divine Presence as the ultimate healer.

שם הגבורה[i] ומיחדים אותה למעלה ולכן הם מהפכים מדת הדין למדת רחמים וממתקים הגבורות ויתרחצו כל אותם המציאות שנחשכו במימי שלג העליון: ויתלבן השחור ויזדכך ובזה עבירות נעשו כזכיות: ובירושלמי דפאה פ״ק מוכח זה מפסוק מור ואהלות קציעות כל בגדותיך ובגדותיך יהיה מלשון בגידה. חזי במדרש רבה: אחר שהתודה החולה החכם יעשה לו התרת קללות[ii] להתיר ולהרחיק ממנו כל קשר בוגדים שנתאחזו בו ובנפשו ע״י איזה סבות כמו קללת עצמו או קללת אחרים שהם המכבידים עליו החולי וזהו ולא ידבק בידך מאומה מן החרם. כי הם המעכבים וענינם המונעים התפלה ואסותא דרחמי מלמעלה ואז ישוב ה׳ מחרון אפו כי קשר רשעים ובוגדים אינו מן המנין ובסלוק הקללה ממילא יחולו הברכות על ראשו:[iii]

supernal snow; the black becomes white and is purified, and through this, transgressions are turned into merits. In the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah, Chapter 1, this is proven from the verse: "Myrrh and aloes, cassia, all your garments," where "your garments" (begadotecha) is derived from the word for "betrayal" (begidah). See this in Midrash Rabbah.

After the sick person has confessed, the sage should perform for him the nullification of curses, to release and remove from him all bonds of traitors that have taken hold of him and his soul through various causes, such as curses upon himself or curses from others, which aggravate his illness. This is the meaning of "and nothing of the accursed thing shall cleave to your hand," for these are the hindrances and clouds that prevent prayer and the healing of mercy from above. Then "the Lord will turn from His fierce anger," for the bond of the wicked and treacherous is not counted, and with the removal of the curse, blessings will automatically rest upon his head.

פרק כ״ב

Chapter 22

יש צדיקים כשנוטים למות

There are righteous people who, when approaching

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening the judgments' (hamtakat ha-dinim), where suffering accepted with repentance transforms the divine attribute of Severity into Mercy.

[iii] This instruction reveals an important post-confession ritual rarely mentioned in other sources: the nullification of curses (hatarat klalot) performed by a sage to remove spiritual obstacles to healing.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Balak — This reference to the Zohar explains the mystical reason why healing is more readily available in the morning, which relates to the dominance of the attribute of Mercy (Chesed) during morning hours. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — This reference explains the kabbalistic understanding that a person's limbs strengthen at the moment of death as the soul prepares to depart, which is relevant to deathbed rituals. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — This citation supports the claim that the righteous do not suffer from illnesses originating from the 'Other Side' (Sitra Achra), an important kabbalistic distinction regarding the spiritual source of suffering. | Cf. Parashat Ha'azinu — The reference to Parashat Ha'azinu relates to the kabbalistic understanding that healing requires expending the precise amount of resources decreed in heaven, suggesting a metaphysical economy of healing. | Cf. Psalm 20 — This psalm is specifically identified as having seventy words that correspond to seventy celestial appointees and seventy veins in the liver, explaining its efficacy when recited for the sick. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This reference explains the kabbalistic concept that commandments protect specific body parts, creating a correspondence between spiritual observance and physical health. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah — This reference provides scriptural support for the concept that sins can be transformed into merits through repentance, using a wordplay on 'garments' (begadotecha) and 'betrayal' (begidah).

נוטלים ידיהם ואמרו במדרש כי בפטירת משה רבינו עליו השלום קדש עצמו כשרפים.[i] ולכל צדיק יוצאים לקראתו שלש כתות של מלאכים אחת נגד נשמה ואומרת יבא שלום. ואחת נגד הרוח. ואחת נגד הנפש.[ii] וסדר הפסוק מכוון בזה. וממתינין אותו כנראה באדרת האזינו בפטירת רבי שמעון בן יוחאי[iii] יעויין שם באורך. מלבד כמה נשמות צדיקים דקב״ה בעי ביקרהון יותר מברתיכוהי:[iv] ובפרשת ויקהל דף ר׳ ע״ב כי המסדר תקון העליון בתפלה על הסוד שהציע שם הוא כלל גדול ביחוד השבעה היכלות להלביש בהם השכינה בסוד השבע נערות הראויות לתת לה מבית המלך העליון ובקישוט מעשה התחתונים שמתראים ומתהוים בהיכלות לבנת הספיר עצם השמים נגה זכות אהבה ששם

death, wash their hands.[1] It is said in the Midrash that when Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, was passing away, he sanctified himself like the seraphim.[A] For every righteous person, three groups of angels come forth to meet them:[1] one for the neshamah (highest soul level), saying "Let peace come"; one for the ruach (middle soul level); and one for the nefesh (vital soul). The order of this verse is precisely arranged for this purpose. They await him as seen in the Idra of Ha'azinu regarding the passing of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, which should be examined there at length. This is besides the many souls of the righteous whom the Holy One, blessed be He, desires their honor even more than His own chariots. 5R 10R 15R

In Parashat Vayakhel, page 200b, it states that one who arranges the supernal rectification in prayer according to the mystery explained there follows a great principle in unifying the seven palaces to clothe the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) within them. This relates to the mystery of the seven maidens who are fit to be given to her from the house of the supernal King,[B] and through the adornment of the 20R

[A] Or: "he sanctified himself like the burning angels" — The term 'seraphim' specifically refers to a class of angels whose name is derived from the Hebrew root meaning 'to burn.' This alternate translation makes the fiery nature of these angels more explicit, which might be helpful for readers unfamiliar with the specific angelic hierarchy.

[A] Or: "the mystical concept of the seven handmaidens designated for her from the supernal King's palace" — This alternate translation uses 'handmaidens' instead of 'maidens' and 'mystical concept' instead of 'mystery,' which might better convey the technical kabbalistic nature of this passage, referring to the seven lower sefirot that serve the Shekhinah.

[1] This ritual handwashing (netilat yadayim) before death resembles the morning handwashing ritual and symbolizes purification as the soul prepares to transition to the spiritual realm.

[2] This tripartite angelic reception reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the soul consists of three levels (nefesh, ruach, and neshamah), each requiring its own spiritual escort during the transition from physical to spiritual existence.

[i] This refers to a midrashic tradition that Moses prepared for death through a process of spiritual purification, elevating himself to the level of seraphim (fiery angels). This establishes a paradigm for how the righteous should approach death—as a sacred transition requiring preparation rather than something to be feared.

[ii] This describes the tripartite angelic reception of the soul after death, corresponding to the three traditional levels of the Jewish soul: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). Each level receives its own angelic escort, signifying that all aspects of the human spiritual identity are preserved and honored in death.

[iii] The Idra of Ha'azinu is a famous section of the Zohar describing the death of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, the traditional author of the Zohar. His death is portrayed not as a tragedy but as his greatest mystical revelation, transforming death from an ending into a moment of supreme spiritual illumination.

[iv] This phrase, meaning 'whom the Holy One, blessed be He, desires their honor more than His own chariots,' conveys the exalted status of righteous souls. In kabbalistic thought, the divine 'chariots' refer to the angelic hosts that serve God, suggesting that the righteous dead are even more precious to God than the angels.

סוד החבוקין.[v] ורצון ששם
סוד הנשיקין דרחימותא שש
היכלות אלו בהם מתלבשת
השכינה וכלם יחד מתיחדים זה
בזה[i] היינו הרוחניות שבכל אחד
מהם מתיחד ונכלל בחברו ובכח
יחודם זה עם זה מתעלים להיכל
קדש הקדשים ששם נגמר היחוד.
והזכר כח המשפיע יורד שם
ונגמר הזווג באחדותא וחדוותא
בכח רעוא עלאה וחם ג׳ מיני
שפע כנדרש בס״פר בשער
מהות והנהגה בבאור ספירת
הבינה. וסוד עליית היכלות
אלו הוא בסוד תפלה המיושב
מראש היוצר עד גאל ישראל
ובזמן אחדות היכלות אלו זה
בזה אין בהם דין והנצוצות
נבלעים במקוריהם והם נהנים
על רוב שלום ועוברים דרך
כסא הכבוד אכתריאל י״ה ה׳
צבאות כדפירשו בסבא בסוד
מים רבים לא יוכלו לכבות את
האהבה וכן הספירות למעלה
מתעלים זה בזה עד כי מתכנסים
למקוריהם אשר בבינה קדש
הקדשים. והתפלה מעומד הוא
סוד ירידת קדושת ההיכלות
מקדש הקדשים[ii] לאהבה בברכת
אבות וגבורות הוא סוד היכל
הזכות גבורה ושם הקדושה מצד
שמאל ובקדושת השם שם יורדים
הג׳ היכלות להיכל הרצון וממנו
מתפשטים י״ב גבולי אלכסון

lower beings' deeds that appear and manifest in the palaces: the Palace of the Sapphire Brick, the Palace of Heaven's Essence, the Palace of Brightness, the Palace of Merit, the Palace of Love (where the mystery of embraces is found), and the Palace of Will (where the mystery of loving kisses resides).[1] The Shekhinah clothes herself in these six palaces, and they all unite with each other—that is, the spirituality within each one unites with and becomes included in its fellow. Through the power of their unification with each other, they ascend to the Palace of the Holy of Holies, where the unification is completed. There, the masculine power of influence descends, and the union is completed in unity and joy through the power of the supernal will. These are the three types of influence as expounded in the Book [of the Pardes] in the Gate of Essence and Governance, in the explanation of the sefirah of Binah.

The mystery of the ascent of these palaces corresponds to the seated prayer from the beginning of Yotzer until Ga'al Yisrael. During the unity of these palaces with each other, there is no judgment within them, and the divine sparks are absorbed into their sources. They delight in abundant peace and pass through the Throne of Glory—Achtariel Yah, Lord of Hosts—as explained in the Sabba [section of the Zohar] concerning the verse "Many waters cannot quench love." Similarly, the sefirot above ascend into each other until they gather to their sources in Binah, the Holy of Holies.

The standing prayer (Amidah) represents the mystery of the descent of the holiness of the palaces from the Holy of Holies to the Palace of Love in the blessing of the Patriarchs.[2] The blessing of Gevurot

[1] The embraces and kisses mentioned here are metaphors for spiritual union and have no physical connotation. They represent different degrees of mystical communion between the divine masculine and feminine aspects in Kabbalah.

[1] This maps the spiritual mechanics of the Amidah prayer, explaining how each section of the prayer corresponds to interactions between different spiritual realms. This provides insight into how prayer practice prepares one for the afterlife journey described earlier.

[i] This passage names several of the seven heavenly palaces (heikhalot) that feature prominently in Jewish mystical literature. Each palace represents a different aspect of divine manifestation and corresponds to different stages in the soul's ascent in prayer and after death.

[ii] The metaphor of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) 'clothing herself' in the six palaces reflects the kabbalistic concept that divine manifestation occurs through a series of 'garments' or levels of revelation. The unification of these palaces represents the restoration of cosmic harmony.

[i] This explains that the Amidah prayer (the 'standing prayer') facilitates a downward flow of divine energy from higher spiritual realms to lower ones. In kabbalistic thought, prayer functions as a two-way channel: the earlier prayers elevate human consciousness upward, while the Amidah brings divine blessing downward.

עם הכולל שהם י״ג ברכות
אמצעיות. ובעבודה סוד ירידת
ד׳ היכלות להשפיע ולהתעלם
בהיכל נוגה. ובהודאה יורדים
מקודשים ומלאים שפע והוד
להיכל עצם השמים ושם סוד
הכריעה להורידם ולהשפיעם
למטה ושם הברכה מצד ימין
קודם גמר הזווג בשים שלום
שהוא ירידת רוחניות כלם
בהיכל לבנת הספיר ושם
יחוד ב׳ שמות הוי״ה ואדנ״ות
יסוד עלייתם בכוונת השמות
הנזכרים שם וירידתם בסוד
שמות התמורה להיות במט״ט
ששם סוד התמורה בנודע ובן
הספירות מתקדשות ממעלה
למטה ממקורותיהם אשר בעמקי
הבינה אם האצילות באור א״ס
המחיה את כלם. ואחר שהפליג
לדבר בשכר המכוין ביחוד הזה
בכל יום בתפלתו אמר שבשעת
מיתתו שכינה אומרת ינוחו על
משכבותם ויתפתחון ליה תריסר
טורי דאפרסמונא דכיא ולא יהא
מאן דימחי בידיה:[ii] [i]

(Powers) corresponds to the Palace of Merit and Strength, where holiness is from the left side. In the Kedushah (Sanctification), the three palaces descend to the Palace of Will, and from it extend the twelve diagonal boundaries, which, with the one that encompasses them, correspond to the thirteen middle blessings. In the Avodah (Service) blessing, there is the mystery of the descent of four palaces to influence and become concealed in the Palace of Brightness. In the Hodaah (Thanksgiving) blessing, they descend sanctified and full of divine influence and splendor to the Palace of Heaven's Essence. There is the mystery of bowing to bring them down and channel them below, and there is the blessing from the right side before the completion of the union in Sim Shalom (Establish Peace), which is the descent of all spiritual forces to the Palace of the Sapphire Brick. There is the unification of the two divine names YHVH and ADNY, the foundation of their ascent through the intention of the Names mentioned there, and their descent through the mystery of the Names of Exchange to be in Metatron, where the mystery of exchange is known.

60R 65R 70R 75R 80R

Similarly, the sefirot are sanctified from above to below from their sources in the depths of Binah, the Mother of Emanation, in the light of the Infinite One (Ein Sof) who gives life to them all. After expounding on the reward for one who focuses on this unification daily in their prayer, it states that at the time of their death, the Shekhinah says, "Let them rest on their beds,"[A] and twelve mountains of pure balsam

85R 90R

[A] Or: "They shall rest in their resting places" — This alternate translation avoids the potentially confusing literal 'beds' and better conveys the metaphorical meaning of the souls' eternal resting

[i] The 'twelve mountains of pure balsam oil' is a mystical metaphor from the Zohar for celestial rewards awaiting the righteous in the afterlife. The phrase 'none will protest against them' suggests unimpeded access to these divine pleasures, which are typically described as the soul's ability to perceive and enjoy divine light without limitation.

[ii] Cf. Idra of Ha'azinu — This reference strengthens the connection between the deathbed rituals described in Ma'avar Yabok and earlier kabbalistic traditions. The Idra sections of the Zohar are considered among its most esoteric and sacred parts, describing the moment of Rabbi Shimon's death as a moment of supreme spiritual illumination rather than loss. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This reference is crucial as it provides the kabbalistic foundation for the author's understanding of prayer as a cosmic process that affects higher worlds. By citing this specific Zohar passage, the author is establishing a direct connection between proper prayer practices during life and one's spiritual experience at the moment of death. | Cf. Pardes Rimmonim — The author's reference to 'the Book' in the context of the 'Gate of Essence and Governance' likely refers to Pardes Rimmonim by Moses Cordovero, one of the most important systematic works of Kabbalah. This shows the author's integration of multiple kabbalistic sources to explain the spiritual mechanics of prayer and its connection to the afterlife.

oil will open for them,[1] and there will be none who will protest against them.

עוד אמרו כי צריך האדם להשתדל בעולם הזה להכין עצמו לקבל אושפיזין קדישין שהם נשמות יתרות[i] היורדים עם השכינה בשבת לדור עם ישראל כנדרש למעלה וזהו לדורותם לדור אתם וצריך שיעשה האדם לשכינה ולאושפיזין אלו דירה נאה בלבו וכלים נאים באברים שלו ואשה נאה שהיא נשמתו השורה שכינה עליה נקראת נשמת כל חי וכתיב כי בו שבת וינפש דשכינה עילאה היא שבת על ישראל ובתתאה וינפש עליהם ונותנת להם נשמות יתרות שהם בתולות אחריה רעותיה וכמה מלאכים ממונים ומשמשים שלהם הבאים עמהם ונשמות אלו נקראים אושפיזין ואותם שהם מצד אימא עילאה שהם נקראים אפרוחים ונפשות[ii] מצד התתאה נקראים בצים וזהו הפורס סוכת שלום מאימא עילאה והזוכה מקבל אושפיזין שהם נשמות אלו בפנים מאירים

They further taught that a person must strive in this world to prepare himself to receive the holy guests[A] who are the additional souls that descend with the Divine Presence on Sabbath to dwell with Israel, as explained above. This is the meaning of "for their generations, to dwell with them" (Exodus 31:16). A person should prepare for the Divine Presence and these guests a beautiful dwelling in his heart, fine vessels in his limbs, and a beautiful wife, which is his soul[2] upon which the Divine Presence rests, called "the soul of all living beings." Scripture states, "for on it He rested and was refreshed" (Exodus 31:17), meaning that the supernal Divine Presence rests upon Israel, and in the lower realm it refreshes them and grants them additional souls, which are "the maidens who follow her, her companions" (Psalms 45:15). Many appointed angels and attendants come with them, and these souls are called "guests." Those that come from the supernal Mother[B] are called "young birds," and the souls that come from the lower realm are called "eggs," in accordance with "who spreads the tabernacle of peace" from the supernal Mother. One who merits receives these guests—these souls—with a radiant countenance in Sabbath delight in this

place after death, which is the intended meaning in this eschatological context.

[A] Or: "to receive the holy ushpizin" — The term 'ushpizin' is a technical kabbalistic term specifically referring to the seven biblical guests who visit the sukkah during the festival of Sukkot. However, in this context it is being used in a broader sense for the additional souls that visit on Sabbath. Leaving the Aramaic term untranslated would preserve this technical meaning, but the translated version better communicates the meaning to readers unfamiliar with the term.

[A] Or: "from the side of Imma Ila'ah" — Keeping the Aramaic/Hebrew term 'Imma Ila'ah' would preserve the technical kabbalistic terminology, which refers specifically to the sefirah of Binah. The translation 'supernal Mother' communicates the meaning but loses some of the technical specificity.

[1] The 'mountains of pure balsam oil' (טורי דאפרסמונא דכיא) is a metaphor from the Zohar describing celestial delights awaiting the righteous in the afterlife. These are not physical pleasures but represent spiritual illumination and divine knowledge unavailable in the physical world.

[2] This metaphor of the soul as a 'beautiful wife' draws on the kabbalistic understanding of the relationship between body and soul as a marriage, reflecting the larger cosmic marriage between masculine and feminine divine attributes.

[iii] The concept of 'additional souls' (neshamot yeterot) refers to the kabbalistic belief that Jews receive an extra soul on Sabbath that departs at the end of Sabbath. Here the author extends this concept to include the souls of righteous ancestors who visit during Sabbath.

[i] The metaphor of 'young birds' and 'eggs' refers to the kabbalistic hierarchical classification of souls according to their spiritual origin and development. This terminology is drawn from the biblical commandment of sending away the mother bird before taking eggs or young birds (Deuteronomy 22:6-7), which is reinterpreted mystically.

בעונג שבת בעוה״ז כשנשמתו
ורוחו ונפשו יוצאים מן גופו
מקבלים להם גם כן בעולם
הבא בעונג ושמחה רבה וכמו
כן המקבל אורחים ברצון שלם
שהוא כאלו מקביל פני שכינה
כאשר יבא לפנינו כן תתקבל
נשמתו והנלוים עמה ביום
פטירתו שבמדה שאדם מודד
בעולם הזה מודדים לו לעולם
הבא. ועל כן מנהג הצדיקים
סמוך למיתתם לקדש ידיהם[i] כי
בזה מקדשים כל גופם כנודע
יסוד נטילת ידים שהאצבעות הם
רמז לעשרה שליטים העליונים
שהם עשר שמות שאינם נמחקים
שבכחם אדם מתחזק בהם בעולם
הזה ובעולם הבא ורומזים גם כן
לעשר מאמרות כאשר דרש רבי
שמעון בן יוחאי בפרשת תרומה
דף קנ״ו ע״ב. ואור מאמרות אלו
האירו ומאירים לארץ ולדרים.
עוד עשר האצבעות הם דוגמא
לעשר אותיות מילוי שם הוי״ה
באלפין[ii] שהוא חיות האצילות
והוא בגימטריא אד״ם וכמו
שכשנולד האדם רוחצין אותו
מסריות אמו כך בשמת. וכל
עומת שבא כן ילך: ובעוד האדם
בחיים חיותו חייב לנקות גופו

world. When his soul, spirit, and vital soul depart from his body, they too will be received in the World to Come with delight and great joy. Similarly, one who receives guests with complete willingness, as if receiving the Divine Presence—as will be discussed later—so will his soul and those accompanying it[A] be received on the day of his departure, for with the measure that a person measures in this world, it is measured to him in the World to Come.[1]

Therefore, it is the custom of the righteous, as death approaches, to sanctify their hands, for in doing so they sanctify their entire body.[B] As is known, the foundation of hand-washing is that the fingers symbolize the ten supernal rulers,[C] which are the ten divine names that may not be erased. Through their power, a person is strengthened in this world and in the World to Come. They also allude to the ten utterances, as Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai expounded in Parashat Terumah, folio 156b. The light of these utterances illuminated and continues to illuminate the earth and its inhabitants. Furthermore, the ten fingers correspond to the ten letters of the expanded divine name YHVH spelled with alephs,[2] which is the life-force of Atzilut (Emanation) and has the numerical value of "Adam" (man). Just as when a person is born, he is washed from his mother's impurity, so too when he dies. As he came, so shall he depart.

While a person is alive, he is obligated to keep his body clean, for it is in the likeness of the supernal im-

[A] Or: "those attached to it" — The Hebrew 'ha-nilvim' has connotations of attachment or joining rather than merely accompanying. The alternate translation better captures the sense of spiritual connection rather than just physical proximity.

[B] Or: "for by this they sanctify their whole body" — The alternate translation is more literal and maintains the demonstrative 'by this' rather than the explanatory 'in doing so,' which might better preserve the original text's emphasis on the specific ritual act.

[C] Or: "the fingers allude to the ten supernal dominions" — The term 'shalitim' could be translated as 'dominions' rather than 'rulers,' which might better capture the kabbalistic concept of divine governing powers rather than personified entities.

[1] This is an adaptation of a well-known rabbinic principle found in the Mishnah (Sotah 1:7): 'With the measure that a person measures, it is measured to him.' The author applies this principle to hospitality and its spiritual rewards.

[1] This refers to a specific kabbalistic way of writing the Tetragrammaton where each letter is spelled out in full with alephs: יו״ד ה״א ואו״ ה״א. This spelling, known as מילוי אלפין (milui alfin), has the numerical value of 45, equivalent to אדם (Adam).

[ii] This ritual of hand-washing before death became an established practice in Jewish tradition. It symbolizes the purification of the person before meeting their Creator, just as the priests would wash their hands before performing service in the Temple.

[i] This refers to one way of spelling out the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) where each letter is expanded using the letter aleph: הא-ואו-הא-יוד, which equals 45 in gematria, the same as אדם (Adam=45).

כי הוא כדיוקן עליון כדאמרי׳ חייב אדם לרחוץ פניו בכל יום משום כבוד קונו ואם אינו עושה כן משליט עליו כחות החצונים התחתונים. כדאמרי׳ ערבוביתא דרישא מתיא לידי עוירא ערבוביתא דגופא מתיא לידי שיחני וכיבי. ערבוביתא דמאני מתיא לידי שעמומיתא. ולדעתי יתהוה לאדם חסרונות אלו[i] מכחות היוצאים מכל אחד מארבע יסודות שבעולם הזה המושפעים מהגלגלים המונעים מכח הקליפות שהם לבר ממדורי העשיה קודם הגלגלים והאדם מחובר מהם ולהיותם מגלגל הירח ולמטה הם מטונפים כדאמרי׳ על שרא דעניותא דנביל שמיה ונביל קרו ליה ואינו דר אלא במקום הטנופת. ואמרי׳ בזהר פרשת תצוה דף קמ״ה בדרוש יום הכפורים דכל מה דנחתין דרגין תתאין הכי מסאבו דלהון יתיר: [ii]

age. As our Sages taught, "A person is obligated to wash his face daily out of respect for his Creator." If he does not do so, he allows the lower external forces to gain control over him. As they said, "Disorder of the head leads to blindness; disorder of the body leads to boils and sores; disorder of garments leads to dullness of mind." In my opinion, these deficiencies arise in a person from forces emanating from each of the four elements of this world, which are influenced by the celestial spheres, which are impeded by the power of the kelipot (husks/shells) that are outside the dwelling places of Asiyah (Action), preceding the spheres. Man is composed of these elements, and being from the sphere of the moon and below, they are contaminated. As they said concerning the prince of poverty, "His name is Naval (vile), and they call him Naval, and he dwells only in a place of filth." And it is stated in the Zohar, Parashat Tetzaveh, page 145, in the discourse on the Day of Atonement, "The lower the levels descend, the greater their impurity."[1]

פרק כ״ג

Chapter 23

עוד יש לנו לדעת כי גם בכל אחד משבעה כוכבי לכת יש

We should also know that in each of the seven planets[2] there are spirits corresponding to each of

[2]This reflects the fundamental kabbalistic principle that spiritual impurity increases as one moves further from the divine source, with the material world being furthest from the source and thus containing the greatest potential for impurity.

[1]In medieval cosmology, these would be the seven 'planets' visible to the naked eye: the Moon, Mercury, Venus, the Sun, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn.

[ii]Here the author transitions from quoting traditional sources to offering his own interpretation, marked by the phrase 'in my opinion.' This demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok combines authoritative tradition with the author's own insights.

[iii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The text directly cites this passage from the Zohar to establish the correspondence between the ten fingers and the ten divine utterances of creation, supporting the mystical significance of hand-washing. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Tetzaveh — The text directly quotes this Zohar passage to explain how spiritual impurity increases as one descends through the spiritual worlds, supporting the author's explanation of bodily cleanliness. | Cf. Exodus 31:16-17 — The text reinterprets these biblical verses about Sabbath observance in a mystical way, suggesting that the phrase 'for their generations, to dwell with them' refers to the divine souls that visit on the Sabbath, and 'He rested and was refreshed' refers to the Divine Presence resting upon Israel. | Cf. Psalms 45:15 — The text repurposes this verse, which originally describes royal maidens accompanying a princess, to describe the additional souls that accompany the Divine Presence on Sabbath, illustrating how biblical verses are given new mystical interpretations. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Shabbat 25b — While not directly quoted, the text echoes the Talmudic concept of 'oneg Shabbat' (Sabbath delight), extending it beyond physical pleasure to include the spiritual delight of hosting divine souls, showing how the author elaborates on Talmudic concepts.

רוחות מקבילות לכל אחד מהם. וכח הארץ וכל אשר עליה נתנה ה׳ בכוכבים ומזלות לפי הנהגתם ומבטם בהם. ועל הכוכבים ומזלות שם הבורא מנהיגים מלאכים ושרים שהם נפש להם.[i] ושם בכח המנהיגים דרכי תמורות וכחות להמיר אשר למטה מהם וימירו אותם הפנים העליונים מבט הכוכבים כפי רצון הבורא וזהו מהשנא עדניא וזמניא והופך לבקר צלמות מבלי שנוי טבעו של עולם וזהו סוד אמרם הכשפים שהם מכחישים לפמליא של מעלה.[ii] ירצה שהם הפך הכחות הפשוטים והם הכחשה לפמליא בצד מהצדדים לכן אסרה אותם התורה כי אין ראוי לאדם לשנות העולם ממנהגו ומטבעו הפשוט שהוא חפץ בוראו. וזה טעם אסור הכלאים כי יבואו מן ההרכבות צמחים ויעשו פעולות נכריות יולידו שנויים ממנהגו של עולם לרע או לטוב כאשר כתב הרמב״ן בפרשת שופטים.[iii] עוד

them. The power of the earth and all that is upon it was given by God to the stars and constellations according to their conduct and their aspect to them.[A] And over the stars and constellations, the Creator appointed angels and princes who are their souls. And there, through the power of these rulers, He established ways of transformations and forces to transmute what is below them, and these supernal aspects will transform the appearance of the stars according to the Creator's will.[B] This is the meaning of "He changes the times and the seasons" and "turns deep darkness into morning" without changing the natural order of the world. This is the secret of their saying that sorceries "contradict the heavenly host."[C] That is to say, they oppose the simple forces and are a contradiction to the heavenly host in some respects. Therefore, the Torah prohibited them, because it is not proper for a person to change the world from its natural course and simple nature, which is the Creator's desire. This is the reason for the prohibition of diverse kinds,[1] for from these combinations plants will emerge and perform strange actions, causing changes in the world's natural order for bad or for good, as Ramban wrote in the portion of Shoftim. He further wrote that since the celestial princes

[A] Or: "God placed the power of the earth and everything upon it under the influence of the stars and constellations, according to their movements and their astrological aspects" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the astrological concept being discussed, using more precise terminology that better reflects the technical nature of the Hebrew terms 'הנהגתם' (their governance/movements) and 'מבטם' (their aspect/gaze).

[B] Or: "and the supernal countenance transforms the influence of the stars according to the Creator's will" — This translation better captures the mystical concept of 'הפנים העליונים' (the supernal face/countenance), which in Kabbalah often refers to divine aspects that mediate between God and creation. Also, 'מבט הכוכבים' refers more to the stars' influence or aspect than merely their appearance.

[C] Or: "sorceries that "deny the celestial retinue"" — This alternate translation preserves the rabbinic terminology 'pamalia' (retinue/entourage) more literally, which carries connotations of a royal court, reflecting the hierarchical structure of the celestial realm as envisioned in Jewish mysticism.

[1] This refers to the biblical prohibition against mixing different species in planting, breeding animals, and wearing garments of mixed materials (kilayim).

[i] This reflects the Neoplatonic and kabbalistic concept that spiritual beings (angels) serve as the animating force or 'soul' for celestial bodies, creating a hierarchical chain of being from God through the celestial to the terrestrial realms.

[ii] This refers to a Talmudic statement (Sanhedrin 67b) that explains why sorcery is called 'keshafim'—because it contradicts (makhishim) the heavenly retinue (pamalia shel ma'alah). The author is integrating this rabbinic saying into his kabbalistic framework.

[i] This refers to Nachmanides' (Ramban's) commentary on Deuteronomy 18, where he discusses the prohibition of divination and sorcery. Ramban explains that these practices interfere with the divine order established in creation.

כתב כי להיות השרים נפשות
לכדורי הגלגלים ושרי זנב וטלה
הקרובים לארץ והם נקראים
נגידי התלי[i] יודיעו העתידות
ומהם נעשים סימנים בעופות
שבהם יודיע עתידות ולא לזמן
גדול וזהו כי עוף השמים יוליך
את הקול וגו׳ וקוסם ומנחש
יקבלו העתידות הנזכרים מן
הכוכבים ומצורותיהם שהם
שלשים ושש. ואולי מספר זה
נגד שלש מערכות מי״ב גבולים
המתראים למעלה או מן השפלים
בשרי מעלה. אבל הנבואה
תודיע חפץ ה׳ ולא יפול דבר
מכל דבריה. וללבנה בפרט
תהיה לה מבטים הרבה ומנהיגים
הרבה הן לטוב הן למוטב הנה
שכח הנוחשים והקוסמים שולט
במזלות להיות כחם מחשרים
חצונים והכל ברצון גבוה: וחטא
אדם גרם כי חל כח חצוני גם
בעולם הגלגלים[ii] וכוכבי השמים
שפגיעתם רעה מאז נתן בהם
איכותם שפיטתם[iii]

are souls to the spheres of the celestial orbs, and
the princes of Scorpio and Aries are close to the 30R
earth[A]—and they are called the rulers of the
Dragon's Head—they make known future events.
From them, signs are made through birds by which
future events are foretold, though not for a great
length of time. This is the meaning of "for a bird of 35R
the sky shall carry the voice, etc." And diviners and
soothsayers receive the aforementioned predictions
from the stars and their forms, which are thirty-six
in number.[1] Perhaps this number corresponds to
three orders of the twelve boundaries that appear 40R
above, or from the lower entities through the
supernal princes. But prophecy makes known God's
desire, and none of its words will fail. The moon in
particular has many aspects and many rulers, both
for good and for ill. Thus, the power of diviners and 45R
soothsayers prevails in the constellations because
their power derives from the external princes, yet all
is according to the supreme will.[2] Adam's sin caused
external forces to take effect even in the world of the
celestial spheres and stars of heaven, whose impact 50R
became harmful from the time their qualities and
judgmental nature were placed in them.

[A] Or: "and the princes of the Dragon's Tail and Aries who are close to the earth" — The Hebrew 'זנב' likely refers to Zanav (the Dragon's Tail or Cauda Draconis) rather than Scorpio. In traditional astrology, the Dragon's Tail (South Node) and Dragon's Head (North Node) are significant points where the moon's orbit intersects the ecliptic plane, and are often mentioned alongside zodiacal constellations like Aries (טלה).

[2] In ancient astrology, the sky was divided into 36 decans (ten-degree segments of the zodiac), each with its own ruler and influence. This appears to be what the author is referencing.
[3] The author emphasizes that even these astrological influences ultimately operate under divine sovereignty, maintaining the Jewish theological principle that God remains in control of creation.

[ii] The 'teli' (dragon or serpent) in Jewish mystical tradition refers to an imaginary celestial axis or the constellation Draco. Sometimes it is associated with the lunar nodes (the points where the moon's orbit intersects the ecliptic), known as the Dragon's Head and Tail in traditional astrology.
[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that Adam's sin had cosmic consequences, not just affecting the terrestrial world but even corrupting the celestial spheres. This idea appears in Lurianic Kabbalah as part of the broader concept of cosmic brokenness requiring tikkun (repair).
[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 35 — This passage continues the discussion about celestial bodies and their influence on terrestrial affairs, expanding on the kabbalistic understanding of cosmic hierarchy and how divine power flows through celestial intermediaries. | Cf. Nachmanides (Ramban) on Deuteronomy 18 — The author directly cites Ramban's commentary to substantiate his explanation of why mixing species and performing sorcery violate divine will by interfering with the natural order established by God. | Cf. Daniel 2:21 — The phrase 'He changes times and seasons' (מהשנא עדניא וזמניא) is drawn from Daniel 2:21, establishing that while God may change cosmic arrangements, humans should not attempt to do so through prohibited means. | Cf. Zohar II:171b — The concept that stars and planets have angelic 'souls' governing them reflects Zoharic cosmology, which presents a universe where every material entity has a spiritual counterpart and governor. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 10:20 — The citation 'for a bird of the sky shall carry the voice' directly

לכך כי אין הוראות רעות בשמים
אם לא אחר שנתעכר העולם
וזהו ארירת האדמה דלא תוסף
תת כחה הזן לך והיא מעלה
לך יתושין וצרעין שמתחלה
רצתה לעשות רצון קונה ואדם
נברא ממנה שהיה תפוח עקבו
מכהה גלגל חמה[i] להיותה אז
משוללת עכירות וכח חיצוני.
וראיה לזה כי גם עתה על ידי
צדקה וחסד מתבטלת גזרתם
באשר היה לבת רבי עקיבא
ושמואל ואבלט.[ii] ולעתיד לבא
יחזרו הדברים על קדמותן הטוב
והותר. ואפי׳ יצר הרע אשר היה
לאדם לא יהיה לו עוד: וזהו
סוד שמים החדשים וארץ החדשה
אשר הקב״ה עתיד לעשות כי לא
תהיה לא בשמים ולא בארץ כי
אם איכות רוחניות קדוש וזהו
כי נשכחו הצרות הראשונות
וגו׳. וטעם זה הוא כי הנני בורא
שמים חדשים וארץ חדשה ולא
תזכרנה הראשונות פי׳ הצרות
ולא תעלינה על לב. ועיין עוד
בפרשת תרומה איך עון אדם
הראשון גרם חסרון גם במקום
אור עליון. על כן צריך האדם
בעולם הזה לקדש עצמו ואל
יניח לכחות חצונים לשלוט

Therefore, there are no evil portents in the heavens except after the world became polluted,[A] and this is the meaning of the curse of the earth that "it shall no longer yield its strength to you" and instead it brings forth gnats and hornets. Originally, it desired to fulfill the will of its Creator, and Adam was created from it; indeed, the ball of his heel dimmed the orb of the sun,[B] because the earth was then devoid of impurity and external force. Evidence for this is that even now, through charity and kindness, their decree is nullified,[1] as happened with Rabbi Akiva's daughter and with Samuel and Ablat. In the future, things will return to their original good state and even better. Even the evil inclination that existed within man will exist no more.

This is the secret of "the new heavens and the new earth"[2] that the Holy One, blessed be He, will create in the future, for there will be nothing in the heavens or on earth except holy spiritual quality. This is the meaning of "for the former troubles are forgotten, etc." The reason for this is: "For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered"—meaning the troubles—"nor come to mind." Examine further in the portion of Terumah how the sin of the first man caused deficiency even in the place of supernal light. Therefore, a person must sanctify himself in this world and not allow external forces to control his body in any way possible.

In Tziyoni on the portion of Yitro concerning the

[A] Or: "the world became turbid" — The Hebrew 'nit'aker' conveys the idea of something becoming cloudy or turbid, like clear water becoming muddy. This alternative is more literal but less immediately comprehensible in the context of cosmic corruption.

[B] Or: "the apple of his heel darkened the sphere of the sun" — The Hebrew 'tappuach' can be translated as 'apple' or 'ball' (describing a rounded protuberance), and 'galgal chamah' could be rendered as 'sphere of the sun' rather than 'orb'. This alternative preserves more of the literal meaning but might be less clear to modern readers.

[1] This reflects the rabbinic concept that tzedakah (charity) and chesed (loving-kindness) have the power to avert negative celestial decrees, including those determined by astrological influences.

[2] This is an eschatological concept drawn from Isaiah 65:17 and 66:22, describing the complete cosmic renewal that will occur in messianic times. In Kabbalistic thought, this renewal represents the universe returning to its original perfect state before Adam's sin.

references Ecclesiastes 10:20, which the author reinterprets in a mystical context to explain how birds can serve as omens or transmitters of celestial information.

[ii] This phrase refers to a rabbinic teaching that Adam's original stature and radiance were so magnificent that even his heel outshone the sun. This illustrates humanity's original perfected state before the Fall.

[iii] This refers to two separate Talmudic stories: one about Rabbi Akiva's daughter who was saved from a fatal snake bite by giving charity to a poor man, and another about Samuel and the astrologer Ablat, demonstrating that righteous deeds can change astrological fate.

בגופו בכל האפשר לו: ובציוני
בפרשת יתרו על פסוק לא תעשה
לך פסל ובפרשת אחרי מות
בסוד שעיר המשתלח שם תמצא
דברים חדשים המכוונים לדרוש
זה. עוד שם בפ׳ אחרי מות דף
ס״ו וס״ז: ועיין בזהר פרשת כי
תשא דף קפ״ח טעם הטועים שהיו
משתחוים לאור קודם זריחת
השמש לממונה שהיו קורין אותו
אלהים דמרגלאן דנהיר והיו
נשבעים בו ואמר שהוא ממונה
על הזהב ועל המרגליות אדומות
ובו היו יודעים נקודות השמש
למצא זהב ומרגליות. ואולי ד׳
בחות תחתונים הנזכרים בדברי
חכמים נתהוו מארבע יסודות
של אדם הראשון בק״ל שנה
שפירש מאשתו[i] אבל הכשופים
פרש״י שע״י מלאכי חבלה הם
נעשים: ועיין מזה בהרשב״א
תשובה תי״ג. ועיין מחלוקי כתות
אלו בר״מ פרשת כי תצא דף
רע״ו: וישראל הוזהרו בוהיה
מחנך קדוש ולא יראה בך ערות
דבר וכן אמרו המשים אוכלים
תחת המטה רוח רעה שורה
עליהם ושומר נפשו ירחק מהם
ויהיה נפשו וגופו וביתו מדור
לקדושה. ובשום פנים אל יגדיל
צפרניו מידיו ורגליו.[ii] ואל ילך
ד׳ אמות בבקר קודם רחיצת
ידיו[iii] כאשר הזהיר ס״ה מזה
פעמים רבות ועל זה נאמר
ונשמרת מכל דבר רע: ואמרו

verse "You shall not make for yourself a graven image," and in the portion of Acharei Mot regarding the secret of the scapegoat, you will find new insights relevant to this interpretation. Also see there in the portion of Acharei Mot, pages 66 and 67. And examine in the Zohar, portion of Ki Tisa, page 188, the reason for the error of those who would bow to the light before sunrise, to an appointed being whom they called "the god of shining pearls," and they would swear by it. It was said that this being was appointed over gold and red pearls, and through it they would know the sun's positions to find gold and pearls. Perhaps the four lower powers mentioned in the words of the Sages[1] originated from the four elements of Adam during the 130 years that he separated from his wife, but regarding sorcery, Rashi explained that they are performed through angels of destruction.

See more on this in Rashba's Responsa 413. Also examine the divisions of these groups in Ra'aya Mehemna, portion of Ki Tetze, page 276. Israel were warned "your camp shall be holy"[2] and "no unseemly thing shall be seen among you." Similarly, they said that one who places food under the bed, an evil spirit rests upon it, and one who guards his soul should distance himself from these things. His soul, body, and home should be a dwelling place for holiness. Under no circumstances should he let his fingernails or toenails grow long. And he should not walk four cubits in the morning before washing his hands, as the author of Sefer HaChasidim warned many times, and regarding this it is said: "You shall guard yourself from every evil thing."

They said in the portion of Terumah that the image of a person stands in his likeness and form in

[1] The author is likely referring to the four primary demonic forces or kelipot (shells) in Kabbalistic cosmology that emerged as a result of cosmic corruption after Adam's sin.

[2] The author is establishing a connection between ritual purity laws in the Torah and Kabbalistic practices for spiritual protection, suggesting that the biblical commandments serve as protection against negative spiritual forces.

[i] According to rabbinic tradition, Adam separated from Eve for 130 years after the sin of the Tree of Knowledge as a form of penance. During this time, various demonic entities were said to have been created from his nocturnal emissions.

[i] In Kabbalistic thought, fingernails are considered a physical manifestation of din (judgment) and can attract negative forces if allowed to grow too long. This instruction reflects practical Kabbalistic hygiene.

[ii] This refers to the ritual of netilat yadayim (ritual hand washing) upon awakening. According to Kabbalistic teaching, during sleep the soul partially departs the body, allowing an impure spirit (ruach ra'ah) to enter, which remains on the hands until washed away.

בפרשת תרומה כי הדיוקן של
120 אדם עומד בדמותו בצלמו
באוצר אחד ששם כל הנשמות של
העולם מתלבשים בדיוקנא. [i]

a certain treasury where all the souls of the world are clothed in their image.[A]

ואולי מקום זה יקרא חצר
ונקרא עבר הנהר. ובזה נדע
125 למה בני ישראל נקראים עבריים
וזה יהיה האוצר שאומר רש״י
על מאמר עד שיכלו כל הנשמות
שבגוף. וי״מ כי גוף ירצה גוף
אדם הראשון שהיו כל הנשמות
130 תלויים בו מהם בראשו ומהם
בזרועותיו כדאמרו חז״ל. [ii] ולכן
כלם צריכים תקון קודם ביאת
הגואל. וחצר זה מבדיל בין
יצירה לעשיה כי הוית הנשמות
135 שתחלת מוצא שפעם מבינה אינם
מצטיירים עד כי יתייחדו ת״ת
ומלכות [iii] ע״י שתי כחות שהם
בהיכל לבנת הספיר ושם בכחם
הנשמה מצטיירת בצורת רמ״ח
140 אברים רוחניים. ובעת שמוכנים

This place is perhaps called a "courtyard" and is known as "beyond the river." This helps us understand why the Children of Israel are called "Hebrews" [Ivrim, from "ever" meaning "beyond"].[1] This would be the storehouse that Rashi refers to in his comment on the statement "until all the souls in the body are depleted." Some interpret that "body" here refers to the body of Adam, the first man, in whom all souls were contained[2]—some in his head, others in his arms, as our Sages taught. Therefore, all souls require rectification before the arrival of the Redeemer. 120R 125R 130R

This courtyard separates the world of Formation [Yetzirah] from the world of Action [Asiyah]. For although souls originate from Binah [Understanding], they do not take form until Tiferet [Beauty] and Malkhut [Kingdom] unite through two forces present in the Palace of the Sapphire Brick.[3] There, through 135R

[A] Or: "in a treasury where all the souls of the world don their iconic form" — The Hebrew 'mitlabshim be-diyokna' conveys the idea of souls putting on or being clothed in their image/form. This alternative captures the active nature of this process and the technical sense of 'diyokna' as an iconic representation.

[1] The text makes a linguistic connection between 'Ivrim' (Hebrews) and 'ever ha-nahar' (beyond the river), suggesting that the Jewish people's very name reflects their souls' celestial origin.

[2] I've clarified that this refers to Adam, the first human, to avoid confusion with the concept of 'Adam Kadmon' (Primordial Man) found in other kabbalistic texts.

[1] This is a reference to one of the celestial palaces described in Heikhalot literature and the Zohar. The Hebrew term 'livnat ha-sapir' comes from Exodus 24:10, describing what was under God's feet in Moses' vision.

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 65:17 — The author uses this verse to support his eschatological vision where the cosmos will be restored to its original spiritual purity, free from the corruption introduced by Adam's sin. | Cf. Genesis 3:17-18 — The author refers to the curse placed on the earth after Adam's sin, where the earth was told it would no longer yield its produce easily and would bring forth thorns and thistles. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Shabbat 156b — The author refers to the famous Talmudic story where Rabbi Akiva's daughter was predicted by astrologers to die on her wedding day, but was saved because of a charitable act she performed. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah — The author refers readers to this section of the Zohar for further explanation of how Adam's sin created a deficiency even in the highest spiritual realms. | Cf. Deuteronomy 23:15 — The author cites this verse to emphasize the importance of maintaining personal and environmental purity as part of one's spiritual practice. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Pesachim 112a — The author refers to the Talmudic warning that food placed under a bed becomes contaminated by evil spirits, using this as an example of the need for physical purity.

[iv] This refers to the rabbinic concept that all future human souls were contained within Adam's body at creation, an idea found in several midrashic sources including Genesis Rabbah.

[i] This describes the kabbalistic process of soul formation, where souls originate from Binah (Understanding) but only take form when Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) and Malkhut (Kingdom) unite, representing the balance of masculine and feminine divine energies.

הנשמות שהם מעבר הנהר עליון
לירד לעולם הזה קורא הקב״ה
לממונה אחד שברשותו מופקדים
כל הנשמות העתידים לבא
לזה העולם ומביא לפניו אותה
הנשמה מלובשת בדיוקן העולם
הזה[i] והקב״ה משביעה שתעסוק
בסוד הנאמנות עליון דכתיב
אתה הראת לדעת כי ה׳ הוא
האלהים בסוד הנאמנות ובסוד
התורה. וה׳ הוא האלהים בו
יחוד עליון ותחתון שמע ישראל
ובשכמל״ו.[ii] ע״כ צריך האדם
לנהוג כבוד ונקיות בגופו זה
לכבוד שמים[iii] בעודו בעה״ז
כי דוגמתו יזכה לו בהתלבשו
בגן עדן עליון ותחתון ולזה
יכוין בנקיות גופו ובגדיו וביתו.
ומזה נבין אסור האבל ברחיצה
כל שבעה כפי הדין. ובגיהוץ
ובתספורת כל שלשים כאשר יבא
לקמן בעה״י. ואמרו בזהר רוח
אמשיך רוח ואיתי רוח: ואמר כי
בכל אתר דבר נש אתקשר הכי
אתחזי באנפוהי. ולכן הצדיקים
נקראים פני שכינה כי השכינה
מתתקנת עמהם ליראות את פני
המלך העליון[iv] ושכינה עמהם
בסתימו ואינון באתגלייא:[v]

these forces, the soul is formed with a structure of 248 spiritual limbs.[1]

When the souls that are "beyond the upper river" are ready to descend to this world, the Holy One, blessed be He, calls upon an angel who is entrusted with all souls destined to enter this world. This angel brings before Him the soul already clothed in the likeness of this world. The Holy One then makes the soul swear to engage in the mystery of supreme faithfulness, as it is written: "You have been shown to know that the Lord is God" in the mystery of faithfulness and in the mystery of Torah. "The Lord is God" contains both the higher and lower unification: "Hear O Israel" and "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever." 140R 145R 150R

Therefore, one must treat one's body with honor and cleanliness for the sake of Heaven while in this world, because its counterpart will be merited when clothed in the upper and lower Garden of Eden. This should be one's intention in maintaining the cleanliness of one's body, garments, and home. From this we can understand the mourner's prohibition against bathing for all seven days according to the law, and against laundered garments and haircuts for all thirty days, as will be explained later, God willing. 155R 160R

And they said in the Zohar: "Spirit draws spirit and brings spirit."[2] And it states that in whatever state a person attaches himself, so it appears on his face. This is why the righteous are called "the face of 165R

[2]The number 248 corresponds to the traditional count of positive commandments in Jewish law and the number of limbs in the human body according to Talmudic anatomy. This establishes a correspondence between the spiritual and physical body.

[1]This Zoharic phrase expresses the principle that similar spiritual qualities attract each other across different realms, explaining how one's spiritual state in this world shapes one's experience in the next.

[ii]This refers to the concept that souls receive a preliminary 'garment' or form that corresponds to their future physical body before descending to earth.

[iii]This describes the two fundamental unifications in Kabbalah: the higher unification expressed in 'Shema Yisrael' (uniting YHVH with Elohim) and the lower unification expressed in 'Baruch Shem Kevod' (uniting upper and lower worlds).

[iv]The author derives an ethical principle from this mystical cosmology: one should treat one's physical body with dignity and cleanliness because it corresponds to the soul's spiritual 'garment' in the afterlife.

[i]This expresses the kabbalistic concept that the righteous become a 'chariot' or vehicle for the Divine Presence, allowing it to be manifest in the lower worlds.

[ii]Cf. Zohar — The text directly quotes the Zohar regarding how spirit draws spirit, establishing the kabbalistic principle that spiritual entities attract their counterparts across different realms. | Cf. Rashi's commentary — The author cites Rashi's interpretation of the Talmudic saying about souls being depleted from a celestial storehouse, using it to support his own cosmological framework. | Cf. Palace of the Sapphire Brick — This reference to the 'Palace of the Sapphire Brick' draws from

the Divine Presence," because the Shekhinah adorns Herself with them to appear before the Supernal King—the Shekhinah is with them in concealment while they are in revelation.[1] 170R

פרק כ״ד

Chapter 24

צריך לדבר דברי תורה עם הנוטה למות אם הוא מיושב בדעתו ובר הכי[i] הוא שכן עשו לרבי אליעזר הגדול. כי תורה היא תבלין ומלח הממתקת הבשר והשבר.[ii] וכל שכן שנותנת עלוי לנשמה רוחנית וכל עוף בלתי טהור פורח ממנו כנראה מכמה מעשים דבגמרין דלא הוה מ״ה יכיל למקרב משום דלא הוה שתיק פומיה מגירסא[iii] ועוד ראיה מרשב״י מאדרת האזינו דאמר ומלין אלין הוו טמירין בלבאי וכו׳ דלא אעייל לעולם הבא בביסופא. והמת מתוך

One should discuss words of Torah with a person who is approaching death, if they are of sound mind and capable of it,[A] as was done for Rabbi Eliezer the Great. For Torah is a spice and salt that sweetens the flesh and the brokenness.[2] And all the more so, 5R it elevates the spiritual soul, and every impure bird (harmful spiritual force) flees from it, as is evident from several stories in our Gemara where the Angel of Death was unable to approach[B] because the person's mouth did not cease from study.[3] Further proof 10R comes from Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai in the Idra of Ha'azinu, who said, "These words were hidden in my heart... so that I would not enter the World to Come in shame." And one who dies amid the joy of Torah study—this is a good sign for them. It is similar to 15R

[A] Or: "worthy of it" — The Aramaic phrase 'bar hachi' can connote both capability and worthiness/appropriateness, depending on context.

[A] Or: "the Angel of Death could not come near" — This is a more literal translation of the Aramaic expression. The acronym מ״ה stands for מלאך המות (Malach HaMavet), the Angel of Death.

[2] This paradoxical statement expresses a key mystical concept: the Divine Presence operates through righteous individuals while remaining hidden, while the righteous themselves are visible in the world.

[3] The original Hebrew uses 'והשבר' (and the brokenness), which has multiple meanings—it can refer to physical fracture, emotional distress, or spiritual crisis. In the context of approaching death, all these meanings are relevant.

[1] The original uses the Aramaic expression 'דלא הוה שתיק פומיה מגירסא' which literally means 'his mouth did not remain silent from study,' a common Talmudic expression for continuous Torah learning.

Heikhalot literature and the Zohar's system of celestial palaces where divine processes occur, specifically where souls take form through the union of divine attributes. | Cf. Deuteronomy 4:35 — The biblical verse 'You have been shown to know that the Lord is God' is used to demonstrate the soul's obligation to acknowledge divine unity, which becomes part of its celestial oath before descending to earth. | Cf. Shema and Baruch Shem declarations — The reference to 'Hear O Israel' (Shema) and 'Blessed be the name...' (Baruch Shem) represents the two fundamental unifications in Jewish mystical practice, connecting upper and lower divine realms.

[iii] The phrase indicates two requirements for Torah study with the dying: mental clarity ('settled mind') and spiritual capacity ('worthy/capable of it'), showing that Torah study with the dying was not merely ritualistic but required their active participation when possible.

[iv] This metaphor comparing Torah to spice and salt has deep significance in Jewish mystical thought. Salt preserves and purifies while spices enhance—suggesting Torah both protects the soul during transition and elevates it spiritually.

[i] This reference to Talmudic stories indicates a belief that continuous Torah study could literally ward off the Angel of Death, showing the perceived protective power of Torah beyond metaphorical understanding.

שחוק של תורה סימן יפה לו. כמו שאמרו שצריך לישן מתוך דברי תורה כי אז תעלה נשמתו בהבל התורה להתדבק בעץ החיים. ותורה היא אור לנשמתו וסימן טוב לצדיק הנפטר ביום לידתו כדאמרי׳ הקב״ה משלים שנותיהם של צדיקים מיום ליום וזה לפי שביום הלידה המזל השולט אז הוא עוזר לו כמו שבו יצא למציאות העולם כדאמרו בירושלמי מסכת ר״ה פרק ראוהו ב״ד עמלק בשפן היה מעמיד בני אדם ביום גניסייא שלו לומר לא במהרה אדם נופל ביום גניסייא שלו שהוא יום הלידה כדאמרי׳ יום גניסייא של מלכים. וכן אם פניו ודעתו כלפי העם העומדים עליו לסעדו בדברי קדושה סימן יפה לו וכן אם גשמים מזלפים על מטתו מורה התעוררות הרחמים עליו. עוד הוא רמז מי יתן טהור מטמא כד״א ועסותם רשעים וגו׳ וכיון דיתייחיב על ההוא עפר מים בדין הוא טהור מטמא. ואדם הוא אפר והמים עליונים מטהרים אותו. עוד ירמוז כי יזכה להעלות נשמות רשעים מגיהנם מדי עברו שם[i] כאשר כתבנו לעיל: כתב בעל הלכות כיון שאדם נטה למות אינם רשאים ליפרד ממנו כדי שלא תצא נפשו כשהוא יחידי וימות בעגמת נפש. מפני שהנפש משתוממת בשעה שיוצאה מן הגוף ועוד שמא יתקשו אבריו ויבא לידי גנות כדאמרי׳ ד׳ צריכים שמור ובהיות רבים עמו מתחלש כח

what they said about the need to fall asleep while engaged in words of Torah, for then one's soul ascends through the breath of Torah to cleave to the Tree of Life. Torah is a light for one's soul, and it is a good sign for a righteous person to pass away on their birthday, as our Sages said, "The Holy One, blessed be He, completes the years of the righteous from day to day." This is because on the day of birth, the ruling constellation helps the person, just as it did when they came into existence in the world. As they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Rosh Hashanah, chapter "The Court Saw Him": "Amalek in Shafan would position people on his anniversary day,[A] saying, 'A person does not easily fall on his anniversary day,' which is the birthday, as we say, 'the anniversary day of kings.'" Similarly, if the dying person's face and mind are turned toward the people standing around them to support them with words of holiness, it is a good sign. And likewise, if rain drips upon their deathbed, this indicates an awakening of divine compassion for them. This also alludes to "Who can bring purity from impurity?"[1] as it is said, "And you shall trample the wicked, etc." And since water is given upon that dust, it is pure from impurity. A person is dust, and the supernal waters purify them. It further hints that they will merit to elevate the souls of the wicked from Gehenna when passing through there, as we wrote above. The author of Halakhot wrote that once a person is near death, others are not permitted to leave them, so that their soul should not depart while they are alone and die in anguish. This is because the soul is bewildered when it leaves the body, and also because their limbs might stiffen and become undignified, as our Sages said, "Four things require watching." When many people are with the dying person, the power of harmful spirits and agents of judgment is weakened, as they said, "Three do not see and are not harmed." For the coarse husks (negative forces) control the

[A] Or: "Amalek son of Shafan would station people on his commemoration day" — The reference is unclear and may be to a historical figure rather than the biblical Amalek. 'Shafan' could be a person's name rather than a place.

[1] This is a quote from Job 14:4, often used in rabbinic literature to discuss spiritual transformation. Here it's connected to rain on a deathbed, suggesting that death itself can be a purifying process.

[i] This remarkable concept suggests that the righteously departed can rescue souls from Gehenna as they pass through it, indicating that the journey after death involves not just personal salvation but potentially helping others as well.

המזיקים ושלוחי הדין כדאמרי׳ ג׳ אינם רואים ואינם ניזוקים כי הקליפות הגסות שולטים בגוף וממיתים אותו. והדקות שולטין בנשמה[1] ופוגמין אותה. ותקונה במיתה לעבל הרע ההוא כמו שיבא. ובזה העומדים עליו עושים תועלת לגופו ונייחא לנשמתו. וראיה מפרקא קמא דחגיגה ממעשה דר׳ יעקב אישכ פר חיטיא יעו״ש. והמסתיר מעשיו בחייו מבני אדם יהיה נסתר מבעלי הדין במותו ואחר מותו ג״כ. [ii]

body and kill it, while the subtle ones control the soul and blemish it. Its rectification in death is to process that evil,[1] as will be explained. In this way, those standing by the dying person provide benefit to their body and comfort to their soul. Evidence for this comes from the first chapter of Hagigah, from the story of Rabbi Jacob of Kfar Hittaya, see there. And one who conceals their deeds from people during their lifetime will be hidden from the agents of judgment at their death[2] and afterward as well.

55R

60R

מלבד כי שכר העושה מצות ועוסק בתורה בפרהסיא הוא ע״י כחות המלאכים המשמשים את הגן. והעובד בסתר שברו הוא ע״י הקב״ה בעצמו. דכתיב ביה מה רב טובך אשר צפנת ליראיך. וכמו שצפון מעשיו כן זוכה לטוב הצפון: ואמרו בספר הזהר כי בשעת פטירתו של אדם הנפש נשאלת מהגוף כאדם ההולך דרך רחוקה ונפרד מאוהבו שקשה בעיניו פרידתו ממנו ואם בחייו זכה להכניע יצר הרע שבו בכחו זה יכנעו הדינין והקליפות מעליו. ועליו יאמר והנה טוב מאד זה מלאך המות

Moreover, the reward of one who performs commandments and engages in Torah study publicly comes through the angelic forces that serve the Garden. But one who serves in private receives his reward directly from the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is written, “How abundant is Your goodness that You have stored up for those who fear You.” And just as his deeds are hidden, so too he merits the hidden good.

The Zohar teaches that at the time of a person’s passing, the soul is requested from the body like a person traveling a distant road who separates from his beloved, finding the separation difficult. If during his lifetime he succeeded in subduing the evil inclination within him, through this power the judgments and negative forces will be subdued from upon him.

65R

70R

75R

80R

[1] The Hebrew term ‘לעבל’ (to process/digest) uses a digestive metaphor for spiritual purification, suggesting that death is a metabolic process where impurities are separated from the essential self.
[2] The concept of ‘בעלי הדין’ (agents of judgment) refers to spiritual entities that evaluate souls after death. The text suggests that privacy in religious practice during life creates spiritual protection after death.

[ii] This kabbalistic teaching distinguishes between ‘coarse husks’ that affect the body and ‘subtle husks’ that affect the soul, reflecting a sophisticated understanding of different levels of spiritual impurity and their varied effects.
[iii] Cf. Talmud, Bava Batra 116a — The author draws on this talmudic source to establish the halakhic basis for studying Torah with a dying person, showing this was not merely a spiritual practice but one rooted in rabbinic tradition. | Cf. Zohar, Idra d’Ha’azinu — The author uses this reference to demonstrate how even the greatest kabbalist, Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, was concerned with proper spiritual preparation before death, specifically through Torah study and teaching. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Rosh Hashanah — The author connects this concept to the idea that dying on one’s birthday is auspicious, suggesting a complete spiritual cycle. This further emphasizes the importance of spiritual preparation, as even astrological factors play a role in the transition. | Cf. Talmud, Hagigah 3b — This reference is used to provide evidence for the author’s claim about the importance of having people present at the time of death to provide comfort and spiritual support.

כמשל בן חשר והזונה בפרשת תרומה דף קס״ג[i] דודאי יצר הרע שהוא שטן טוב מאוד למאן דצאית פקודין דמאריה וירחם לקב״ה גם ביצר הרע בתר דתבר ליה. ואם היצר משיאו לדבר עבירה והוא להחלישו ילך לעשות דבר מצוה נגדו אשריו כי בזה מניה וביה אבא ליזיל ביה נרגא.[ii] ובהתרחקו מג׳ קליפות הגאוה ואבזריה שהם רו״ח גדולה. ורע״ש וא״ש[iii] הנה הם ג׳ חלקי העשיה דהיינו עשיה ויצירה וחלק הבריאה שבעולם ההוא כי חלק האצילות שבה היא קליפת הנוגה שיש לה מתוק בכח מלוי שם ב״ן שהיא בשבינה על ידי (מטמא) אות אחת המלוי בכל יום. והתרגום שהתורה ירדה ברוכה בו הוא רמז לקליפה זו שהיא ראש לקומת החיצונים. שכן רישיה דדהבא שהיא לשון כשדיים וארמית. ועליה נאמר כי נופת תטופנה שפתי זרה וחלק משמן חכה. אך אחר התפשטות הראש ליוני וביוצא אחריתה מרה כלענה וגו׳. וזהו אמרם יפת אלהים ליפת שפירוש יפיפותו של יפת שהוא לשון ארמי ישכון באהלי שם.[iv] שכן קליפה זו מקבלת מיתוק ורצונה בכך ולכן מלאכת האדם בעוה״ז להבדיל עצמו מהג׳ קליפות הנזכרים התחתונות ולמתק חלק

Of such a person it is said, “And behold, it was very good”—this refers to the Angel of Death, as in the parable of the prince and the prostitute in Parashat Terumah, page 163, where the evil inclination, which is Satan, is truly good for one who heeds the commandments of his Master and serves the Holy One, blessed be He, even through the evil inclination after he has broken it. And if the inclination entices him to sin, but he weakens it by performing a commandment instead, fortunate is he, for in this way “from itself comes the ax handle” [to fell the tree].

By distancing himself from the three kelipot (husks) of pride and its accessories—which are “great wind,” “earthquake,” and “fire”—these representing the three parts of Asiyah, namely Asiyah, Yetzirah, and the portion of Beriah within that world, since the Atzilut portion within it is the kelipat nogah (luminous shell), which has sweetness through the power of the filled Divine Name Ban, which is in the Shekhinah through the filling of one letter each day.[1] The Aramaic translation with which the Torah descended intertwined is an allusion to this kelipah, which is the head of the external forces’ structure. For “its head is of gold” refers to the Chaldean and Aramaic language. Of this it is said, “For the lips of a strange woman drip honey, and her palate is smoother than oil.” But after the extension of the head to Greek and similar languages, “her end is bitter as wormwood,” etc.

This is the meaning of the saying, “May God extend Japheth, and he shall dwell in the tents of Shem,” which means that the beauty of Japheth, which is the Aramaic language, shall dwell in the tents of Shem. For this kelipah receives sweetening

[1] This refers to a complex kabbalistic concept about how divine names are ‘filled’ by spelling out each letter in full, creating an expanded form. The text suggests this process happens gradually, with one letter being filled each day.

[i] This refers to a parable in the Zohar (Terumah 163) where the king’s son enters a prostitute’s house to test him. Similarly, the soul is tested by the evil inclination, and when it resists temptation, the evil inclination itself becomes beneficial.

[ii] This Aramaic expression literally means ‘from itself comes the ax handle’—a metaphor suggesting that the solution to a problem comes from the problem itself. Here it means that the evil inclination is defeated using its own energy redirected toward good.

[iii] These terms refer to the manifestations that Elijah experienced at Mount Horeb: ‘great wind,’ ‘earthquake,’ and ‘fire,’ in which God was not present (1 Kings 19:11-12). Here they symbolize three levels of impure forces.

[i] This is a kabbalistic interpretation of Genesis 9:27. In this reading, ‘Japheth’ represents the beauty of translation (particularly Aramaic), which can dwell in the ‘tents of Shem’ (representing Hebrew, the holy tongue) when properly purified.

העשיה זו הראשונה. וזהו שם
120 הטומאה שמסר אברהם לבני
הפילגשים. כי בראותו שהיו
נוטים אל החצונים בקש שלא
ידבקו בקליפות גסות החצונות.
אבל ידבקו אל תוכיות הטומאה
125 שעליו הוא השם. כי מלת שם
אינו מוסב על החומר אלא
על הצורה. והיא קליפה דקה
פנימית הנאכלת כמה פעמים
עם האגוז. ונקל לאחוזים
130 בקליפה רביעית זו הנקראת
נוגה להדבק אח״כ בקדושה:
ונקראים כחות אלו מתנות
שהם כלם דברים הדיוטים
מאותם שקרא אותם הרמב״ם ז״ל
135 מפורסמות שבני אדם להוטים
אחריהם. המפורסמות שהם
מאילן הדעת טוב ורע נחלקים
לארבע חלקים יש חלק שהוא
טוב במוחלט וחלק תחתון רע
140 במוחלט. ואחר חלק הראשון בא
חלק שני שיש בו מהרע אך הטוב
הוא יותר מהרע הרבה ואח״כ
בא החלק הג׳ שבו יותר חלק
הרע מהטוב. והחלק הראשון
145 ממנו זהו שם טומאה שמסר
להם[i] שבאותו שם מתעסקים
באומניות כשרים שעליהם אמר
התנא שיגיעת שניהם משכחת עון
וזהו יגיע כפיך כי תאכל כפי
150 ההכרח אשריך וטוב לך. שבזה
תזכה לטוב עץ הדעת החלק
שהוא טוב במוחלט. והביא
המשורר ראיה מהמשגל שיש בו
טוב ורע ולירא ה׳ הוא כלו
155 טוב. וזהו אשתך כגפן פוריה
וגו׳ ומעין זה היו המתנות שלקח
משה בשמים עבור ישראל שהם
טובות גשמיות שמיעדת התורה
לעושי רצונו להכנות. ולא
160 עבור שכר מצוה כי ליכא בהאי

and desires it, and therefore man's task in this world 115R
is to separate himself from the three lower kelipot
mentioned above and to sweeten this first part of
Asiyah. This is the "name of impurity" that Abra-
ham gave to the children of his concubines. For
seeing that they were inclined toward the external 120R
forces, he desired that they not cleave to the coarse
external husks, but rather adhere to the inner essence
of impurity, which is designated by the name. For
the word "name" does not refer to the substance but
to the form. And it is a thin, inner husk that is 125R
sometimes eaten with the nut. It is easy for those
who grasp this fourth kelipah called nogah to subse-
quently cleave to holiness.

These powers are called "gifts," and they are all
common matters of the type that Maimonides, of 130R
blessed memory, called "widely accepted notions"
that people eagerly pursue. These widely accepted
notions, which come from the Tree of Knowledge of
Good and Evil, are divided into four parts: there
is a part that is absolutely good and a lower part 135R
that is absolutely evil. After the first part comes a
second part that contains some evil, but the good
in it far outweighs the evil. Then comes the third
part, in which the evil portion exceeds the good.
The first part is this "name of impurity" that he 140R
gave them,[1] through which they engage in proper
occupations, concerning which the Tanna said that
"the toil of both of them makes sin forgotten." This
is the meaning of "When you eat the labor of your
hands according to necessity, you are fortunate and 145R
it is good for you." Through this you will merit
the good of the Tree of Knowledge, the part that is
absolutely good.

The Psalmist brought proof from sexual relations,
which contains both good and evil, yet for one who 150R
fears the Lord, it is entirely good. This is the mean-
ing of "Your wife shall be as a fruitful vine," etc.
Similar to this were the gifts that Moses took in
heaven for Israel, which are physical benefits that
the Torah designates for those who do His will, as 155R
preparation—not as reward for the commandment,

[1] The concept of Abraham giving a 'name of impurity' to his concubines' children isn't explicitly mentioned in the Bible but comes from kabbalistic tradition. It represents practical, worldly knowledge that, while not purely sacred, still has positive value when used properly.

[ii] This references the tradition that Abraham gave esoteric knowledge to the children of his concubines (Genesis 25:6). The author interprets this as knowledge of practical occupations that, while not purely sacred, still connect to divine service at their highest level.

עלמא אלא עבור מתן שכר. דמתן שכר זה נתן בהאי עלמא להכנת הטוב. ובהתרחק האדם מג׳ חלקים התחתונים שבעץ הדעת טוב ורע הנזכרים גם כן נשמתו לא תצטער בהם. ותצא בקול דממה דקה כי שם הארת פני שכינה ע״י כח אריה אשר יתראה בנגדו כנתבאר בהקדמת תקוני הזהר דף ג׳ ע״ב. ולא יאונה אליו כח כלב ח״ו שהוא דין חצוף המתהווה מזווג קליפת שור וחמור.[i][ii]

for "there is no reward for commandments in this world," but rather for the giving of reward, as this giving of reward is granted in this world as preparation for the good.

When a person distances himself from the three lower parts of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil mentioned above, his soul will not suffer through them. It will depart in "a still, small voice," for there the illumination of the Divine Presence shines through the power of the lion that appears before him, as explained in the introduction to Tikkunei Zohar, page 3b. And he will not be afflicted, Heaven forbid, by the power of the dog, which is insolent judgment formed from the union of the husks of ox and donkey.

ואם לא נהנה מתענוגי העולם הזה אלא מסעודת מצוה גם כן בשרו ישכון לבטח[iii] דהואיל ולא

And if one has not enjoyed the pleasures of this world except through meals associated with religious commandments, his flesh will also dwell securely,[1] for

[1]The original uses a biblical phrase (ישכון לבטח) that has both physical and spiritual connotations. In this context, it means the body will be protected from harmful spiritual forces after death due to its purity in life.

[i]In kabbalistic symbolism, the 'dog' represents brazen judgment that results from an improper combination of spiritual forces (symbolized by ox and donkey, which the Torah forbids from being yoked together). This negative spiritual energy may manifest at death for the unprepared soul.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Terumah 163 — The passage refers to a parable in the Zohar (Terumah 163) about the prince and the prostitute, which illustrates how the evil inclination (yetzer hara) can be transformed from an adversary into something beneficial when properly subdued. | Cf. Psalm 31:20 — The quote 'How abundant is Your goodness that You have stored up for those who fear You' comes from Psalm 31:20 and is used to support the idea that those who serve God in private receive direct divine reward. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Introduction 3b — The reference to the 'power of the lion' appearing before the righteous person at death comes from Tikkunei Zohar's introduction, which discusses the four faces of the divine chariot (lion, ox, eagle, human) and their manifestation at different spiritual moments. | Cf. Genesis 9:27 — The verse 'May God extend Japheth, and he shall dwell in the tents of Shem' is from Genesis 9:27, but is given a kabbalistic interpretation where Japheth represents Aramaic language (associated with translation) and Shem represents Hebrew (the holy tongue). | Cf. 1 Kings 19:11-12 — The three manifestations of 'great wind,' 'earthquake,' and 'fire' allude to the story of Elijah at Mount Horeb (1 Kings 19:11-12), where God was not in these powerful forces but in 'a still, small voice,' which the text also references regarding the soul's departure. | Cf. Proverbs 5:3-4 — The quote 'For the lips of a strange woman drip honey, and her palate is smoother than oil' is from Proverbs 5:3, and 'her end is bitter as wormwood' is from 5:4. The text applies these verses metaphorically to the allure and danger of certain types of external wisdom. | Cf. Genesis 25:6 — The reference to Abraham giving 'gifts' to the children of his concubines comes from Genesis 25:6. The text gives this a mystical interpretation, suggesting these 'gifts' were a form of knowledge related to the 'name of impurity'—practical wisdom that kept them from the worst forms of idolatry. | Cf. Ethics of the Fathers 2:2 — The phrase 'the toil of both of them makes sin forgotten' appears to reference the teaching in Pirkei Avot (Ethics of the Fathers) 2:2 that Torah study combined with work is beneficial because the exertion of both makes sin forgotten.

[iii]This phrase alludes to Psalm 16:9, "Therefore my heart is glad, and my glory rejoices; my flesh also shall rest in confidence." In this context, it refers to the body being protected from harmful spiritual forces after death.

נטל מחלק רוח מסאבא[i] כלום
ליה ליה רשו עליהון כלל
וזכאה איהו מאן דלא מתהני
מדיליה כלום. והשומר פיו
ולשונו מכל מאכל ודבור רע
שומר מצרות נפשו. כדאמרי׳
בסוף פ׳ משפטים באיסור בשר
בחלב ואפילו לאכול אותם
בשעתא חדא או בסעודא חדא
אמר כי מתראה בפניו גדי
מקולס[ii] לגבי עליונים. וכתות
טמאים מטמאים אותו וגורם
לעורר דינים חצונים. ואם
יוליד בן באותם מ׳ יומין ממשיך
עליו נשמה מסטרא אחרא. ועל
זה בני משפחתנו צוו והוזהרו
מהחסידה זקנתי אם אמי מרת
פיורי״טה דמתקרייא בת שבע
אלמנת המנוח כמוהר״ר שלמה
יעקב רפאל ממודינ״ה.[iii] שלא
לאכול אפי׳ חלב ואח״כ בשר
אם לא כשיעור שיש בין סעודה
לסעודה. וכן נהגנו עד היום
הזה. זה כתבתי לזרז בני ביתי
והנלוים אליהם ממשפחתנו
לבל ישנו תפקידתם וכזה פסק
בעל הלבושים[iv] סימן קע״ג.
ואמר שם בס״ה כי חנניה מישאל
ועזריה צלמא דמאריהון לא
אתעדי מנהון[v] בגין דלא אתענגו

since he has taken nothing from the portion of the impure spirit, it has no power over him at all. And fortunate is he who does not benefit from that which belongs to it. One who guards his mouth and tongue from all forbidden food and evil speech guards his soul from troubles. As it is stated at the end of the chapter Mishpatim regarding the prohibition of meat and milk, even eating them in the same hour or at the same meal, it says that a kid appears roasted before the celestial beings. And groups of impure entities defile him and cause external judgments to be aroused. And if he fathers a child during those forty days, he draws upon it a soul from the Other Side.[1]

Concerning this, the members of our family were commanded and warned by my pious grandmother, my mother's mother, Lady Fiorita, who was called Bat Sheva,[2] widow of the deceased, the honorable Rabbi Shlomo Yaakov Raphael of Modena, not to eat even milk and afterward meat unless allowing the time equivalent to the interval between one meal and another.[3] And so we have practiced until this day. I have written this to encourage my household members and those attached to them from our family not to change their assigned duty. And similarly ruled the author of the Levushim in section 173.

And it is stated there in Sefer HaZohar that Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah—the image of their Master did not depart from them[4] because they did not indulge in the contamination of their vessels.

175R 180R 185R 190R 195R 200R

[2]"The Other Side" (סטרא אחרא) is a kabbalistic term for forces of impurity and evil, essentially the demonic realm opposed to divine holiness.

[3]This shows the practice of having both secular/vernacular names (Italian "Fiorita") and Hebrew names ("Bat Sheva") common among Italian Jews of this period.

[4]The text is discussing the halakhic requirement to wait between consuming dairy and meat products. Different traditions specify varying waiting periods; here the author's family follows a practice of waiting the time equivalent to between regular meals.

[1]This is a mystical concept suggesting that adherence to dietary laws preserves the divine image (tzelem) in humans. The Zohar teaches that forbidden foods damage this spiritual image.

[ii]"Ruach mesaava" (spirit of impurity) is a kabbalistic term for negative spiritual forces that gain power over a person through forbidden foods and actions.

[iii]"Gedi mekulas" refers to a roasted kid/goat, which was a forbidden idolatrous practice. The author is using this as a metaphor for how eating meat and milk together appears in the spiritual realms.

[iv]This passage provides valuable biographical information about the author's family. His maternal grandmother was named Fiorita (an Italian name), also called Bat Sheva in Hebrew, and she was the widow of Rabbi Shlomo Yaakov Raphael of Modena.

[i]"Ba'al HaLevushim" refers to Rabbi Mordechai Jaffe (1530-1612), author of a series of halakhic works collectively known as the "Levushim" (Garments).

[ii]This Aramaic phrase refers to Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah (from the Book of Daniel) retain-

בגיעולי מכליהון ושים עיניך על מה שכתב ספר הזהר על פסוק כל עמל האדם לפיהו וגם הנפש לא תמלא כי ודאי בזה כל הירא וחרד לנפשו יעשה משמרת למשמרת[i] לבל יכנס בפיו שום דבר אסור ויפקח עיניו מי שוחט מי בודק ומי מנקר הבשר וכ״ש שאר אסורין המצויין ודבר זה צריך זרוז מאד כי מכשלה רבה היא. ואמרו בויקרא רבה פרשה י״ג אריסטון[ii] עתיד הקב״ה לעשות לעבדיו וכל מי שלא אכל נבלות בעולם הזה זוכה לראותו לעולם הבא הה״ד וחלב נבלה וחלב טרפה יעשה לכל מלאכה ואכול לא תאכלוהו בשביל שתאכלו ממנו לעתיד לבא ע״כ. וזוהי הסעודה של ג״ע[iii] בראו הנביאים לא מתן שכר הצדיקים כדאמרי׳ במדרש.[iv]

And set your eyes upon what the Zohar wrote on the verse "All the labor of a man is for his mouth, and the soul is never satisfied," for certainly in this matter, everyone who fears and trembles for his soul will make a safeguard around a safeguard[1] so that nothing forbidden enters his mouth. And he will keep his eyes open regarding who slaughters, who examines, and who removes the forbidden parts from the meat,[2] and all the more so regarding other common prohibitions. This matter requires great diligence, for it is a major stumbling block.

And they said in Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 13, "The Holy One, blessed be He, will make a feast (ariston)[3] for His servants in the future, and anyone who did not eat forbidden meat in this world will merit to see it in the World to Come." This is what is written: "The fat of an animal that died of itself, and the fat of one that is torn by beasts, may be used for any work; but you shall not eat it"—so that you may eat of it in the time to come. This is the feast of the Garden of Eden which the prophets created, not the reward of the righteous, as stated in the Midrash.

ובמדבר רבה פרשה י״ג אמרו שהקב״ה מיסב עם הצדיקים אלו בסעודת גן עדן דכתיב יבא דודי

And in Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah, chapter 13, they said that the Holy One, blessed be He, reclines with these righteous ones at the feast in the Garden of

[2]This translates the rabbinic principle of creating additional protective measures (משמרת למשמרת) to prevent violations of Torah law. I've rendered it idiomatically to capture the concept of multiple layers of protection.

[3]This refers to "nikur" (ניקור), the process of removing forbidden fats, veins and sinews from kosher meat, particularly the sciatic nerve (gid hanasheh) which is biblically prohibited.

[4]I've included the transliterated Greek-derived term "ariston" in parentheses to clarify the foreign term used in the original text.

ing the "image of their Master" (divine likeness) because they refused to eat forbidden foods in Nebuchadnezzar's palace.

[iii]"Safeguard for a safeguard" is a rabbinic principle of creating additional protective measures to prevent violations of Torah law. Here it refers to being extra cautious about food laws.

[iv]"Ariston" is a Greek-derived term meaning a banquet or feast. In rabbinic literature, it refers to the eschatological banquet that the righteous will enjoy in the World to Come.

[v]"The feast of Gan Eden (Garden of Eden)" refers to the spiritual reward awaiting the righteous after death, often depicted metaphorically as a divine banquet.

[vi]Cf. Sefer HaZohar, Parashat Mishpatim — The passage cites the Zohar's teaching that consuming meat and milk together has negative spiritual consequences, including attracting impure forces and affecting one's offspring. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah 13 — The midrash is cited to support the idea that those who observe dietary laws in this world will merit special rewards in the World to Come, specifically participation in a divine feast. | Cf. Levushim by Rabbi Mordechai Jaffe — The author cites Rabbi Jaffe's halakhic ruling to support his family's stringent practice regarding the separation of meat and milk. | Cf. Book of Daniel, story of Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah — These biblical figures are cited as examples of those who maintained their spiritual purity by refusing to consume forbidden foods at the Babylonian court.

לגנו וגו׳:[i] וכל המונע עיניו
מחטא שומר כל גופו ובהרחיק
עצמו מן ההרהור מקיים העולם
בזכותו ולא תאונה אליו רעה
דעינא ולבא תרי סרסורי
דחטאה נינהו[ii] ואם בסבת
עונותיו יבהלוהו הרהורים
רעים יחשוב בגדולת שמו הגדול
ובפרט בשם הוי״ה מלא ביודין
שהוא שם המחשבה[iii] כתוב לפניו
על קלף כשר כנ״ל. וירגיל
עצמו לקרא פעמים הרבה פסוק
אש תמיד תוקד על המזבח לא
תכבה.[iv] ועיין בתקון שלישי
מהתקונים החדשים סודו שהוא
להבריח השטן ופסוק ויאמר
ה׳ אל השטן וגו׳. ושחט אותו
על ירך המזבח וגו׳ וכדומה
להם. והסדר אשר העלינו
במעירי שחר שלנו ביום ראש
השנה[v] יפה לדעתנו להבריח כל
אויב ומתנקם ולכלות קוצים מן
הכרם וקריאת פסוקי הפרשה
עם התרגום בכל יום למתק

Eden,[1] as it is written, "Let my beloved come to his garden, etc." And whoever guards his eyes from sin[2] protects his entire body, and by distancing himself from impure thoughts, he sustains the world through his merit,[3] and no evil will befall him, for the eyes and the heart are the two agents of sin. And if, due to his transgressions, evil thoughts disturb him, he should contemplate the greatness of His great Name, particularly the Divine Name YHVH spelled fully with Yuds,[4] which is the Name of thought, written before him on kosher parchment as mentioned above. And he should accustom himself to recite many times the verse "A perpetual fire shall be kept burning on the altar; it shall not go out." And see in the third Tikkun of the new Tikkunim its secret, that it is to drive away Satan, and the verse "And the LORD said to Satan, etc." And "he shall slaughter it on the north side of the altar, etc." and similar verses. And the order which we established in our "Me'irei Shachar" on Rosh Hashanah is, in our opinion, excellent for driving away every enemy and avenger, and for removing thorns from the vineyard. And reading the weekly Torah portion with the Targum every day to sweeten

230R 235R 240R 245R 250R

[1] The original uses סעודת גן עדן, literally 'meal of the Garden of Eden,' which is a metaphorical concept in rabbinic literature depicting the ultimate spiritual reward for the righteous as dining with God in Paradise.

[2] The concept of 'guarding the eyes' (שמירת עיניים) is a significant ethical practice in Jewish tradition, referring to the conscious avoidance of looking at inappropriate sights that might lead to sinful thoughts or actions.

[3] This reflects the rabbinic concept that righteous individuals sustain the entire world through their merit (זכות), a theme expressed in the Talmudic statement that the world exists due to thirty-six hidden righteous people.

[4] This refers to a specific spelling of the Tetragrammaton in Kabbalah where each letter is expanded: י״ד ה״י ו״ו ה״י, with the total numerical value of 72. This form is associated with the world of Atzilut (Emanation) and thought purification.

[i] This references Song of Songs 5:1, which is interpreted mystically to refer to God's relationship with the righteous in the afterlife. The metaphor of God 'dining' with the righteous in Paradise is a significant rabbinic concept depicting the ultimate spiritual reward.

[ii] This is a reference to a Talmudic concept (Yerushalmi Berakhot 1:5) that the eye and the heart are 'two agents of sin'—meaning that sin typically begins with seeing something forbidden, desiring it in one's heart, and then acting upon it. This concept is foundational in Jewish ethical literature.

[iii] This refers to a kabbalistic spelling of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) where each letter is fully spelled out using the letter yud (הי-ויו-הי-יוד), giving it a numerical value of 72. In Kabbalah, this expansion is associated with the world of Atzilut (Emanation) and is considered particularly effective for purifying thought.

[iv] This verse from Leviticus 6:6 about the perpetual fire on the altar is interpreted in Kabbalah as a spiritual weapon against impure thoughts. The 'fire' represents divine energy that can purify human consciousness.

[v] The author refers to his own prayer collection called 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), particularly the Rosh Hashanah liturgy, which he claims has special efficacy for spiritual protection.

קליפת נוגה כפי סדר גורי האר״י[i], מסוגל מאד לטהרת המחשבה לע״ד. עוד דבר מסוגל לטהרה זו הוא קריאת פסוקי דזמרא עם שירת הים בקול רנה ותודה בבית הכנסת עם הקהל לא כאותם הכורתים וזומרים אותם ומבליעים שלא בנעימה כי עיניהם על דרכיהם ושמים חשך לאור ואור לחשך. ומצאתי כתוב כי שם אוריאל טוב להארת הנשמה[ii] מכל מה שנתגלה לה במרום כפי כחה שיזכור ממנו ונתגלה ע״י זה סודות נוראות וגם הוא מסוגל לטהר מחשבותיו שלא יהיו נפסלים בתפלתו הדומה לקרבן שנפסל במחשבה. וטוב לת״ח להרגיל עצמו לומר תפלה קצרה זו ובפרט קודם פטירתו:[iii]

the kelipat nogah (shining husk),[1] according to the order of the disciples of the ARI, is very beneficial for purifying one's thoughts, in my humble opinion. Another thing beneficial for this purification is reading the verses of Pesukei d'Zimra along with the Song of the Sea in a voice of joyful thanksgiving in the synagogue with the congregation—not like those who cut and prune them and swallow them unmelodiously, for their eyes are on their ways,[2] and they put darkness for light and light for darkness. And I found it written that the name Uriel is good for illuminating the soul from all that was revealed to it in the heights according to its capacity that it may remember, and through this, awesome secrets are revealed. It is also effective for purifying one's thoughts so they will not become invalidated in one's prayer, which is comparable to a sacrifice that becomes invalidated through improper thought. And it is good for a Torah scholar to accustom himself to recite this short prayer, especially before his passing:[3]

255R 260R 265R 270R

רִבּוֹן עָלְמִין[iv] דְּאַנְתְּ הוּא מָארֵי

Master of the Worlds,[A] You who are the Lord of

275R

[A] Or: "Sovereign of the Universes" — This alternative captures the cosmic scale implied in the

[1] In Lurianic Kabbalah, kelipat nogah is the intermediary 'shell' or 'husk' between the realms of holiness and impurity. Unlike purely negative husks, it contains a mixture of good and evil and can be elevated through proper spiritual actions.

[2] This is a critique of those who rush through prayers mechanically without proper devotion, focusing on their own concerns rather than on the spiritual content of the prayers.

[1] The text ends abruptly here before providing the actual prayer it references. The prayer itself would likely have been a meditation intended for recitation near death, continuing the text's theme of spiritual preparation.

[ii] This refers to the Lurianic kabbalistic practice of 'sweetening' kelipat nogah (the 'shining husk'—a neutral spiritual force that can be elevated to holiness). The disciples of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the ARI) had specific methods for this spiritual rectification.

[iii] Uriel is one of the four archangels in Jewish tradition. In Kabbalah, contemplating angelic names was believed to connect one to their spiritual energies. Uriel, whose name means 'God is my light,' is associated with illumination of the soul and intellect.

[iv] Cf. Song of Songs 5:1 — The verse 'Let my beloved come to his garden' is used to illustrate the intimate relationship between God and the righteous in the afterlife, portrayed as God dining with the righteous in the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Leviticus 6:6 — The verse about perpetual fire on the altar is interpreted as a spiritual tool against negative forces. When recited repeatedly, it is believed to drive away Satan and harmful thoughts. | Cf. Zohar — The concept of 'eyes and heart as agents of sin' derives from rabbinic teachings expanded in the Zohar, which views the body as a microcosm where each organ can either serve holiness or impurity. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The reference to the 'third Tikkun of the new Tikkunim' indicates a section of kabbalistic literature that explains mystical interpretations of biblical verses as tools against spiritual harm. | Cf. Targum (Aramaic translation) — Reading the Torah with its Aramaic translation (Targum) is prescribed as a spiritual practice to 'sweeten' negative forces, following the kabbalistic system of the ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria).

[i] This Aramaic phrase 'Ribon Almin' is a common opening in kabbalistic prayers, addressing God as sovereign over all spiritual worlds, not just the physical universe.

מַלְכִּין וְגָלֵי רָזִין[i] יְהֵא רַעֲוָא דֵּילָךְ לְסַבְּרָא מִלִּין בְּפוּמָאי לְקַיְּימָא בִּי הַאי קְרָא וְאָנֹכִי אֶהְיֶה עִם פִּיךָ דְּלָא אֵיעוֹל בְּכִסּוּפָא קֳדָמָךְ. וְתוֹרָה מְגִינָה וּמַצְלָא מִכָּל מִיתָה מְשׁוּנָּה:[iii ii]

kings and revealer of mysteries, may it be Your will to place words in my mouth[1] to fulfill in me this verse: "And I will be with your mouth," so that I shall not enter into shame before You.[A] And may the Torah shield and protect me from every unusual death.[B]

פרק כ״ה

Chapter 25

הנה בעין האדם בו נרמזו כל השמות הקדושים וכל שעור הקומה והעולם בכללו על כן מאד תועיל שימת עין על פרצופו של אדם בעת פטירתו מלבד מה שכתבנו למעלה. ואמרו בתקון ו׳ דף י״ח כי אור העין רמז לת״ת ובת עין היא בית שלו. והיא מציאות המלכות שיש לה מחכמה מקור החיים בסוד יו״ד בתוך ה״א ומדת המלה צריכה שמירה

Behold, in the human eye are encoded all the holy Names,[2] the entire Divine structure,[3] and the world in its totality. Therefore, it is highly beneficial to focus one's gaze upon the face of a person at the time of their passing, beyond what we have written above. In Tikkun 6, page 18, they state that the light of the eye symbolizes Tiferet, and the pupil is its dwelling place.[A] This represents the existence of Malkhut, which receives from Chokhmah, the source of life, through the mystery of the letter Yod within the letter Hei.[B] The attribute of speech requires great

Aramaic term 'almin' which refers to multiple worlds or universes in kabbalistic thought.

[B]Or: "so that I shall not enter with embarrassment into Your presence" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the spatial metaphor of entering into God's presence, which is implied in the original Aramaic.

[C]Or: "unnatural death" — The term 'meshunah' in this context often refers specifically to deaths that are considered unnatural or premature, rather than simply unusual.

[A]Or: "And they said in the 6th Tikkun, page 18, that the light of the eye alludes to Tiferet, and the pupil is its abode" — This alternate translation is more literal and preserves the term 'alludes to' (remez) rather than 'symbolizes,' which better captures the specific technical meaning in kabbalistic interpretation. The term 'abode' might be preferable to 'dwelling place' for 'bayit shelo' in some contexts.

[B]Or: "This is the manifestation of Malkhut, which draws from Chokhmah, the fountain of life,

[2]The Aramaic phrase 'lesabra milin befumai' literally means 'to understand/explain words in my mouth,' but the context suggests the author is asking for divine inspiration in his speech, hence this slightly interpretive translation.

[3]The Hebrew uses the term 'nirmezu' (נרמזו) which implies both encoding and allusion, suggesting that the divine names are hinted at or encrypted within the physical structure of the eye.

[4]The Hebrew term 'shiur hakoma' (שעור הקומה) is a specific kabbalistic concept referring to the mystical dimensions of the divine body or structure, which was the subject of esoteric texts like Shiur Komah.

[ii]The description of God as 'revealer of mysteries' is particularly significant in a work dealing with the mysteries of death and the afterlife, acknowledging that these topics can only be discussed properly with divine assistance.

[iii]The concept of 'unusual death' (mitah meshunah) has special significance in Jewish tradition, where it is considered a divine punishment. By invoking protection from such a death, the author seeks divine favor before discussing death-related matters.

[iv]Cf. Exodus 4:12 — The prayer invokes God's promise to Moses, asking for divine assistance in speaking properly, suggesting that the author seeks eloquence and accuracy in explaining sacred matters, especially those related to death and the afterlife. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Sotah 21a — The concluding line alludes to the Talmudic teaching that Torah study provides protection from unusual or premature death, indicating the prayer's function as a protective formula before discussing matters related to death and the afterlife.

רבה מפני קרבתה אל הקליפות
וכונה זו יבא הרואה חכמים
ימותו לעורר עליהם מאורות
המתהוים מסוד שם אדנו״ת
והוי״ה משולבים שבהם ומהם כל
אורה ושפע והמבין לאשורו כי
אשר עין בעין נראה אתה ה׳ עם
מ״ש בפ׳ נשא ישמח ויגל במנהגן
של ישראל. דההוא עדן עילאה
נהיר לעדן תתאה ואלמלא עינא
טבא עילאה דאריך דאשגח
לעינא תתאה דזעיר לא יכיל
עלמא למיקם רגע חדא ובעינא
דרישא חיוורא לית גבינא על
עינא דא. פירוש כוחות דינין
דכתיב הנה לא ינום ולא יישן
שומר ישראל דלעילא וכתיב
להיות עיניך פקוחות ורמיז
לדגים ולנוני ימא דלית כסותא
על עינא ולית גבינא. ובדגים
נאמרה בהו אסיפה בצדיקים
במיתתם. והמשכיל ידע ויבין
כי בראותו חכמים ימותו הוא
מקביל ליחוד ב׳ שמות ההוי״ה
הקודמת לי״ג מדות של רחמים.
והרבה יותר ממ״ש באן יש לדרוש
בסוד הזה. וטעם ויוסף ישית ידו
על עיניך יתבונן למבין מזה וכן
למה בזרעא דיוסף לא שליט ביה

protection due to its proximity to the external forces (kelipot).[A] With this intention, one who witnesses the death of sages should arouse for them illuminations that form from the mystery of the interwoven divine names Adonut and YHVH,[1] from which all light and abundance flow. 15R

One who truly understands that "eye to eye they shall see the LORD"[2] together with what is written in Parashat Nassa will rejoice in the customs of Israel. For the supernal Eden illuminates the lower Eden, and if not for the benevolent supernal eye of Arich[3] gazing upon the lower eye of Zeir, the world could not exist for even a moment.[4] And in the eye of the White Head, there is no eyelid over that eye. This means there are no forces of judgment,[5] as it is written, "Behold, the Guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps," and "that Your eyes may be open." This alludes to fish and sea creatures that have no covering over their eyes and no eyelids. Regarding fish, the term "gathering" is used,[6] just as with the righteous at their death. 20R 25R 30R

The wise person will know and understand that when witnessing the death of sages, it corresponds to the unification of the two divine names YHVH that precede the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy. There is much more to expound upon in this mystery than what is written here. The meaning of "and Joseph shall place his hand upon your eyes" will be comprehended by those who understand this, as well as 35R 40R

through the secret of the Yod within the Hei" — This alternate rendering uses 'manifestation' for 'metziyut' which more precisely captures the ontological significance of the term in Kabbalah. The phrase 'fountain of life' for 'mekor hachayim' is more biblically resonant, and 'secret' might be preferred to 'mystery' for 'sod' in some kabbalistic translations.

[A] Or: "The attribute of the word requires careful guarding because of its closeness to the husks" — This alternative uses 'word' instead of 'speech' for 'milah' and 'husks' instead of 'external forces' for 'kelipot,' which might be preferred in some translations. Also, 'careful guarding' has slightly different connotations than 'great protection.'

[1] The Hebrew term 'meshulabim' (משולבים) indicates that these divine names are interwoven or combined in a specific pattern, likely referring to the kabbalistic practice of interweaving the letters of these two names.

[2] This is a reference to Isaiah 52:8, which in context describes the redemption of Jerusalem. The text reinterprets this as referring to direct mystical perception.

[3] The Hebrew 'eina tava ila'ah d'Arich' (עינא טבא עילאה דאריך) uses Aramaic terminology from the Zohar, referring to the 'good eye' of the divine aspect called Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One).

[4] The Hebrew emphasizes the utter dependence of creation on continuous divine supervision, suggesting that existence itself requires uninterrupted divine attention.

[5] The Hebrew phrase 'kochot dinin' (כוחות דינין) specifically refers to forces of divine judgment or severity in kabbalistic terminology, which are symbolized by the eyelid that can interrupt the flow of divine light.

[6] This refers to the Hebrew term 'asifah' (אסיפה) used for both fish dying and the righteous dying, creating a linguistic connection that suggests a spiritual similarity between them.

עינא בישא ובחצוני עין הרע שבו מזיק הרבה כדאמרו והסיר ה׳ ממך כל חולי ואמר רב זה עין הרע. וכן לא יעמוד אדם עם שדה חבירו וכו׳. לא מסתפי מר מעינא בישא דאמרו לר׳ יוחנן. ואמרו חכמי המחקר כי יש בני אדם המזיקים בהבטת עיניהם כאפעה ומרגלא בפיהם העין תכנים הגמל בקדרה והאדם אל הקבורה. ויש חיות הממיתים עד כמטחוי קשת ואמרו כי אלכסנדרוס מוקדון בא עם חילו למקום שהיו בו חיות הממיתים בהבטת פניהם ועשו מראות מצוחצחות ושמו אותם נגד החיות וחזר ראותן אליהן ומתו כלם וזה היה כח בלעם. אמנם נתינת עין האמור בחכמי הגמ׳ הוא כי כח העין רע אשר בת״ח פועלת לפי כוונתם ומחשבתם בחכמת האלהים כדאמרו בזהר חכימין כליהון רשימין אינון דיוקניהון בחכמה השופטת ומענשת עד כי האדם הנענש נקצץ ונשמתו נטלת ממנו. וכל מיתה הוא סילוק אור של מעלה כדכתיב סר צלם מעליהם. וע״כ מכוון הבטת פני הנפטר בעינא פקיחא ובאור נר כי יהל עליו כאשר יבא. [i]

why the evil eye has no power over the descendants of Joseph,[1] while in ordinary people, the evil eye can cause great harm, as they said, “And the LORD will remove from you all illness,” which Rav interpreted as the evil eye. 45R

Similarly, “One should not stand near his neighbor’s field, etc.” They said to Rabbi Yochanan, “Is the master not afraid of the evil eye?” The philosophical scholars said that there are people who cause harm with their gaze like vipers, and there is a saying that “the eye brings the camel into the pot[2] and a person to the grave.” There are creatures that can kill from as far as a bowshot away. They said that Alexander of Macedon came with his army to a place where there were creatures that could kill with their gaze, so they made polished mirrors and placed them before the creatures, causing their gaze to be reflected back at them, killing them all. This was the power of Balaam.[3] 50R 55R

However, the “casting of an eye” mentioned by the Talmudic sages refers to the power of the evil eye that operates in Torah scholars[4] according to their intention and thought in divine wisdom. As they said in the Zohar, “The wise are marked; their image is engraved in the wisdom that judges and punishes,” so that the person who is punished is cut down and his soul is taken from him.[5] Every death is the removal of supernal light, as it is written, “Their protection has departed from them.” Therefore, one should direct one’s gaze at the face of the departed with an open eye and with the light of a candle 60R 65R 70R

[1] The Hebrew ‘lo shalit bei eina bisha’ (לא שליט ביה עינא בישא) literally means ‘the evil eye does not rule over him,’ emphasizing complete immunity rather than mere resistance.

[2] This is a proverbial expression in Hebrew suggesting that the evil eye can cause even something as large as a camel to be reduced to something that fits in a cooking pot, emphasizing its destructive power.

[3] The text creates a parallel between the mythical creatures killed by their own reflection and Balaam’s power, suggesting that his ability to curse operated through a similar visual mechanism.

[4] This is a striking concept suggesting that Torah scholars (talmidei chachamim) possess a form of the evil eye that operates according to divine wisdom rather than malevolent intent, functioning as an instrument of divine judgment.

[5] The Hebrew uses strong terminology (‘niktzatz’—נקצץ) suggesting the person is literally cut down or severed, emphasizing the devastating power of this divinely channeled ‘evil eye’ of the sages.

[i] Cf. Tikkun 6, page 18 — The passage connects the human eye to the divine structure, explaining how the physical eye corresponds to the sefirot Tiferet and Malkhut. This creates a theological framework where gazing at a dying person has profound cosmic significance. | Cf. Parashat Nassa — The text likely refers to the Priestly Blessing in Numbers 6:24-26, which includes ‘May the LORD make His face shine upon you’ and ‘May the LORD lift up His countenance upon you,’ connecting to the theme of divine vision and watchfulness. | Cf. Guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps — This verse is used to illustrate that the divine eye is always watching, without the

shining upon him, as will be explained.[A]

ולהיותה קרוב למקום
המיתה צריך שמירה והארה
כמה שאמרנו על מדת
המלכות.[i] מצאתי כתוב כי
העומד בפני חולה שנוטה למות
ואין שם אדם אחר שיודע בענין
המת לראותו בעת יציאת נשמתו
ומתי ישלים לצאת ולהעצים
עיניו ולהתעסק בו גם שהגיע
זמן תפלה אל יצא משם כדי
להתפלל. אשרי אדם מסקל
ומרים מכשול מדרך המובן
לעלות שם נשמתו[ii] בעודו בעה״ז
כי אמרו בתקונים כי בפי מה
שאדם בונה בעה״ז בהבל פיו
אם שמים חדשים בהבל הקדוש
מחדושי תורה.[iii] או להיפך חם

And being close to the place of death, it requires protection and illumination, as we have said regarding the attribute of Malkhut.[1] I found it written that one who stands before a sick person who is approaching death, and there is no one else there who understands matters concerning the dead—to observe him at the moment his soul departs, and when he will complete his departure, to close his eyes, and to attend to him—even if the time for prayer has arrived, he should not leave in order to pray.[2] Fortunate is the person who clears away and removes obstacles from the path prepared for his soul's ascent while still in this world, for they said in the Tikkunim that according to how a person builds in this world through the breath of his mouth—whether heavens anew through holy breath from Torah innovations,[3] or conversely, Heaven forbid, increasing

[A] Or: "Therefore, one intentionally gazes at the face of the deceased with a watchful eye and with the illumination of a lamp shining upon him, as will be described" — This alternative uses 'intentionally gazes' to better capture the active intention implied by 'mecaven,' and 'watchful eye' for 'eina pekicha' which preserves the specific kabbalistic terminology. 'Illumination of a lamp' has a more ritual connotation than 'light of a candle' which might be preferred in mystical contexts.

[1] Malkhut (Kingdom/Sovereignty) is the tenth and lowest of the divine emanations (sefirot) in Kabbalah, serving as the interface between the divine and human realms. The text refers to earlier discussions about Malkhut's vulnerability and need for protection.

[2] This ruling demonstrates the text's prioritization of proper care for the dying over other religious obligations, even prayer, which is normally considered of paramount importance in Jewish practice.

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that Torah study has creative power, literally generating new spiritual realities. The 'breath' of Torah study is seen as having the same creative potential as God's speech in Genesis.

interruption of eyelids (representing judgment), providing a biblical foundation for the kabbalistic concept of continuous divine providence. | Cf. the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy — The text connects witnessing death to divine compassion, suggesting that at the moment of death there is a special opportunity for divine mercy to be activated through proper intention and ritual. | Cf. Joseph shall place his hand upon your eyes — This biblical verse is reinterpreted in a mystical context to suggest a special spiritual power associated with Joseph regarding protection from the evil eye, both in death rituals and for his descendants. | Cf. Alexander of Macedon — This reference illustrates the literal belief in the power of harmful vision while transitioning to a more mystical understanding of how gazes can affect spiritual reality. | Cf. Their protection has departed from them — The verse is reinterpreted to explain death as the departure of divine light or protection (tzelem/shadow), providing a mystical understanding of death as primarily a spiritual rather than physical phenomenon.

[ii] Malkhut is the lowest of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah, often associated with the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) and considered particularly vulnerable to negative spiritual forces, thus requiring special protection.

[iii] The text uses the metaphor of clearing a path for the soul's ascent, comparing spiritual preparation to the physical act of removing obstacles from a road.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that Torah study creates new spiritual realities, with the phrase 'heavens anew' alluding to Isaiah 65:17 where God promises to create 'new heavens and a new earth.'

ושלום מרבה הפתחים ופותח
90 הסלונות המקבלות טומאה
בהבל של תוהו. באותו הדרך
תעלה נשמתו בעת מותו ושם
תתלונן אח״כ[i] ומזה גם בזהר פ׳
בשלח. ותקון האדם תלוי בימים
95 להיותם צנורות עליונות נמשכות
למטה לתקון הנפש. ושכר הצפון
לצדיקים טמון ונעלם בתוך
הימים שהם צנורות הנמשכים
למלכות אם כל הנשמות[ii] וכל
100 אחד משרי הימים שעברו עליו
אם סגל בהם מצות והרבה בהם
תורת עוז מתקרבים ומתראים
ביום מיתתו כי חיים הם בחיות
אשר השפיע עליהם עם הקשוטים
105 שקשט אותם להליץ עליו זכות
כי הם מוגדלים מכח אור אשר
יהל. והוסיף עליהם מסוד
אילן עץ החיים[iii] שסלסל ורמם
אותו והשקהו ממים היוצאים
110 מבית ה׳ מתוקים והעלה על
שפת הנחל העליון כל עץ נחמד
למראה וטוב למאכל ופארות
עץ החיים התפארו והאירו עד
למרחוק ונתן בכל יום שכרו אם
115 בימי חול מצות הראויות לאותו
יום מעון הספירה ששולטת
בו.[iv] ואם בשבת נתעדן ויחד
בסוד נפשו בראוי. וכן סוכה

doorways and opening thorns that receive impurity through the breath of emptiness[1]—in that same way will his soul ascend at the time of his death, and there it will afterward dwell. And of this, too, in the Zohar, Parashat Beshalach. 90R

A person's spiritual rectification depends on days, as they are supernal channels drawn downward to rectify the soul. The reward reserved for the righteous is hidden and concealed within the days, which are channels flowing to Malkhut, mother of all souls.[2] Each of the angelic princes of the days that have passed over him—if he acquired merits in them and increased in them the Torah of strength—draw near and appear on the day of his death, for they are alive through the vitality that he bestowed upon them, along with the adornments with which he adorned them, to advocate his merit, for they are magnified by the power of light that shines forth. 95R 100R 105R

He added to them from the secret of the Tree of Life, which he exalted and tended,[3] watering it with sweet waters flowing from God's house, and raised up on the bank of the supernal river every tree delightful to the sight and good for food. The branches of the Tree of Life glorified themselves and illuminated to the distance. And he gave his reward each day: on weekdays, the commandments appropriate for that day from the dwelling of the divine attribute that rules it;[4] on Sabbath, he delighted and unified in the secret of his soul as fitting; likewise the sukkah 110R 115R

[2] The metaphor of 'thorns' (silonot) describes negative spiritual pathways created through improper speech or empty words, which then become channels for impurity to enter and affect one's soul.

[3] In Kabbalah, Malkhut is often portrayed as the feminine aspect of divinity and the 'womb' through which souls enter the world and to which they return after death.

[4] The Tree of Life metaphor here represents both Torah study and the divine structure of the sefirot. The person who engages in proper spiritual practice is described as cultivating this Tree, causing it to flourish and extend its influence.

[1] In kabbalistic tradition, each day of the week is associated with a particular divine attribute (sefirah): Sunday with Chesed (Kindness), Monday with Gevurah (Strength), Tuesday with Tiferet (Beauty), etc.

[ii] The text presents the spiritual principle of 'measure for measure' (midah k'neged midah), where the pathways created by one's actions in life become the very channels through which their soul travels after death.

[iii] Malkhut is described as 'mother of all souls' because in Kabbalah it serves as the divine attribute through which souls enter the world and to which they return after death.

[iv] The Tree of Life is a central kabbalistic metaphor representing both the structure of divine emanations and the Torah itself. Here it refers to spiritual accomplishments that nourish one's soul and create merit.

[i] In kabbalistic thought, each day of the week is associated with a particular divine attribute (sefirah): Sunday with Chesed (Kindness), Monday with Gevurah (Strength), etc., with specific mitzvot particularly appropriate to each.

ולולב בסוכות. ומצה בפסח
וכיוצא. ואם לא טוב משה אז
הימים עומדים בכסופא.[i] ואם
עין יצרו הטעתו והריק לאשפה
והגדיל חלק הרע אז טוב ממנו
הנפל[ii] וכל יום מימיו קורא עליו
אל ה׳ ויהיה בו חטא ובאשר משה
כן יעשה לו גמולו ישוב בראשו
כדכתיב הנה סערת ה׳ חמה
יוצאה וגו׳ רחמנא ליצלן.[iii]

and lulav on Sukkot, and matzah on Passover, and similar observances.

But if he did not depart well, then the days stand in shame.[1] And if the eye of his inclination deceived him, and he emptied into filth and magnified the portion of evil, then better than he is the stillborn, and every day of his days calls out to God, "Let there be sin in him." And as he departs, so shall it be done to him—his recompense shall return upon his head, as it is written: "Behold, the storm of the Lord! Fury has gone forth..." May the Merciful One protect us.[2]

ואמרו בפ׳ וארא כד בר נש
ישלים גופיה בפקודין דאורייתא
ליית לך כל יומא דלא אתיא
לאתברכא מניה. וכד אינון
מתברכאן כדין איין ואסוותא
תליין עליה מלמעלה מאן
גרים ליה אינון יומי שתא כמה
דמברכאן מלעילא ברזא דאדם
שהוא ת״ת ששם רמז השנה הנמשך

And they said in Parashat Va'era: When a person perfects himself through the commandments of the Torah,[3] there is not a day that does not come to be blessed through him. And when they [the days] are blessed, then health and healing depend upon him from above.[A] Who causes this? Those days of the year, just as they are blessed from above according to the mystery of Adam, which is Tiferet, where the year is alluded to as flowing from the Sab-

[A] Or: "And when they [the days] are blessed, then the eyes and healing descend upon him from above" — The word 'איין' could be interpreted as 'eyes' rather than 'health.' In Kabbalistic texts, divine eyes often represent providence and watchfulness. This alternate reading suggests that divine supervision and healing flow down when days are properly sanctified.

[2] The Aramaic term 'kisufa' (shame) refers to the metaphysical state of receiving without giving in return. Days that received existence but were not filled with positive actions are described as experiencing this 'shame.'

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'Rachmana litzlan' is an Aramaic prayer formula meaning 'May the Merciful One save/protect us,' typically used after mentioning something negative or frightening.

[4] The original Hebrew phrase 'ישלים גופיה בפקודין דאורייתא' uses Aramaic terminology common in the Zohar. The concept goes beyond mere observance of commandments to suggest a complete harmonization of one's physical existence ('גופיה'—his body) with the spiritual frequencies of Torah commandments.

[ii] The Aramaic term 'kisufa' (shame) is used in kabbalistic literature to describe the metaphysical state of receiving without giving, suggesting that days without spiritual accomplishment feel 'shame' at having provided opportunity that wasn't utilized.

[iii] This references Ecclesiastes 6:3-5, which suggests that a stillborn child is better off than one who lives a long but unfulfilled life.

[iv] Cf. Tikkunim (Tikunei Zohar) — The text cites the Tikkunim (a component text of the Zoharic literature) as a source for the idea that how a person builds in this world through speech determines the path their soul will take after death. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — The text references the Zohar's commentary on the Torah portion Beshalach as supporting the concept that one's spiritual path in life determines the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Tree of Life (Etz Chaim) — The Tree of Life imagery is used metaphorically to describe how one nurtures spiritual growth through Torah study and mitzvot, with the rewards becoming apparent at the moment of death. | Cf. Hevel (breath) — The text uses the concept of 'hevel' (breath) to create a parallel between speech/breath in life and the soul's journey after death, drawing on the kabbalistic understanding that speech has creative power. | Cf. Malkhut (Kingdom) — The reference to Malkhut establishes the kabbalistic framework of the text, as Malkhut is the lowest of the divine emanations and serves as the connection point between the divine and human realms.

מן השמיטין שהוא בינה כדדרשו
ברמז עש״ן תג״ל. כך אתברכון
מתתא ברזא דאדם ועל זה נאמר
ישברו פראים צמאם. ואמרו
בזהר ריש פ׳ פקודי פירוש
פראים הם המרכבות תחתונות.
וכבר כתבנו למעלה שבכל יום
מאיר אור מחלק הוי״ה ידיעה
מי״ב צרופי השם הגדול מלבד
זה יש לכל שעה כח הוי״ה שמאיר
בו ע״כ צריך שבכל יום יעשה
תשובה ובכל שעה יהרהר לפחות
בדברי קדושה ויכוין להאיר
ההוי״ה ששולטת אז. וביון שאחד
מההויות מתחיל להאיר ע״י תקון
מעשיו מיד וקרא זה אל זה. כי
אז כלם מאירים יען לכולם יש
קשור ויחוד וחבור ורוח אחד
לכל המחיה את כלם. נמצא בזה
בכל שעה מאיר לסל העולם
בכללו. ועוד שבכל יום יש לו
מלאך וביון שנמצא לו מלאך
מליץ אחד מני אלף להגיד עליו
יושרו מיד יפדוהו מרדת שחת.
וימציאו לסטרא אחרא כופר
חלופו מניה וביה על דרך ואתן
אדם תחתיך וכו׳ וכן חס ושלום
דרך הפגם. וביום יש בו רוחניות
כל השנה שכן בה ד׳ תקופות.
חצי היום וחצי הלילה. ובין
השמשות. ואילת השחר. והשעה
כוללת כל רוחניות מהיום.
והרגע כל רוחניות של השעה.

batical cycles, which is Binah,[1] as they explained in the allusion "smoke shall rejoice." Similarly, they are blessed from below through the mystery of Adam, and concerning this it is said, "The wild donkeys quench their thirst." 140R

And they said in the Zohar at the beginning of Parashat Pekudei that "wild donkeys" refers to the lower chariots. And we have already written above that each day, light shines from a portion of a specific permutation of the divine name YHVH from the twelve permutations of the Great Name.[A] Besides this, each hour has the power of a divine name YHVH that illuminates it.[2] Therefore, one must repent each day, and in each hour at least contemplate holy matters and intend to illuminate the divine name that rules at that time. And when one of these divine names begins to shine through the rectification of one's deeds, immediately "one calls to another."[3] For then they all illuminate, since they all have connection, unification, and joining, and one spirit for all that gives life to all of them. Thus, in this way, in each hour there is illumination for the entire world collectively. 145R 150R 155R 160R

Moreover, each day a person has an angel, and when there is found for him "one interceding angel out of a thousand to declare his uprightness," immediately "He will redeem him from descending to the pit." And they will provide to the Other Side a ransom in exchange for him from his own substance,[4] according to the principle of "I will give a man in your place," etc., and likewise, God forbid, in the way of defect [sin]. 165R 170R

In a day there is the spirituality of the entire year,

[A] Or: "each day, light shines from a portion of the divine name YHVH, a specific one of the twelve permutations of the Great Name" — This alternate translation clarifies that each day corresponds to one specific permutation of the divine name out of twelve possible permutations, rather than suggesting that light comes from only 'a portion' of a permutation. This reading better aligns with kabbalistic teachings about the correspondence between days and divine name permutations.

[1] This references the kabbalistic understanding that the seven-year Sabbatical cycle (shemitah) corresponds to the sefirah of Binah (Understanding), which is the cosmic source of cycles and rhythms in time. Binah is understood as the spiritual origin of the concept of time itself.

[2] The text describes a complex system where time itself is structured by and infused with divine names. Each division of time (year, month, day, hour) is governed by a specific divine name or permutation of names, creating a cosmic calendar of spiritual energies.

[3] This phrase echoes Isaiah 6:3 describing the angels calling to one another "Holy, holy, holy." Here it suggests that divine names activate each other in a chain reaction of spiritual illumination when properly engaged by human consciousness.

[4] The phrase 'מניה וביה' (from his own substance) suggests that the spiritual exchange or ransom comes from elements within the person's own being, perhaps referring to the transformation of negative aspects into positive ones, or the redirection of certain energies.

באופן שהכל חוזר אל מקורו ולאחדות השלם. ובכל תקופה בין מהשנה בין מהיום ואולי גם כן בשעה יושלחו כל אחד ואחד מפמליא של מעלה איש איש למלאכתו אשר המה עושים. וזהו אדם נדון בכל יום וי״א בכל שעה. וי״א בכל רגע. ובארבע תקופות היום התרנגול הבר אשר שרשו ביסוד עולם. בא אליו נצוץ מכח שרשו ומניע כנפיו דוגמתו. ונותן ליוצר הכל שבח וזהו סימן כי בעת ההיא מקבלים הממשלה כל אחד ואחד על ממלכתו אשר הופקדה עליו: [i]

for in it are four seasons: midday, midnight, twilight, and dawn. And the hour includes all the spirituality of the day, and the moment all the spirituality of the hour, in such a way that everything returns to its source and to complete unity. And in each season, whether of the year or of the day, and perhaps also in the hour, each one of the heavenly host is sent forth, each to his task which they perform. And this is why "a person is judged every day," and some say every hour, and some say every moment.

And at the four seasons of the day,[1] the wild rooster, whose root is in the Foundation of the world,[A] receives a spark from the power of its root and moves its wings accordingly, giving praise to the Creator of all. This is a sign that at that time, each one receives authority over his kingdom which was entrusted to him.

פרק כ״ו

Chapter 26

ראוי לדעת כי בתורה יש ששים רבוא אותיות נגד ששים

It is important to know that in the Torah there are six hundred thousand letters[A] corresponding to the

[A] Or: "the celestial rooster, whose root is in the Foundation of the world" — While 'התרנגול הבר' literally means 'wild rooster,' in kabbalistic contexts it often refers to a celestial or archetypal entity rather than a literal wild animal. This spiritual rooster that announces the changing times is an important motif in Jewish mysticism, representing divine providence marking the transitions between cosmic time periods.

[A] Or: "600,000 letters" — While the original translation is accurate, the numerical expression

[1] The text presents a sophisticated understanding of time where each unit of time (year, day, hour, moment) contains the spiritual pattern of larger cycles within it. This fractal view of time is a key concept in kabbalistic cosmology.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Va'era — This reference establishes the concept that a person who fulfills Torah commandments creates blessing in the world, which affects the cosmic flow of divine energy. This is a foundational idea for understanding how human actions impact spiritual and physical well-being. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — This reference explains the spiritual entities called 'wild donkeys' (פראים) as lower spiritual chariots or vehicles. This helps understand how blessing flows through various levels of reality, from divine to earthly realms. | Cf. Book of Job — The phrase 'one interceding angel out of a thousand to declare his uprightness' and 'He will redeem him from descending to the pit' are direct allusions to Job 33:23-24. This biblical reference provides the foundation for the kabbalistic concept that angels serve as advocates for humans in the heavenly court, particularly when people engage in spiritual rectification. | Cf. Isaiah — The phrase 'I will give a man in your place' alludes to Isaiah 43:4, where God says 'I will give people in exchange for you.' In the mystical context of Ma'avar Yabok, this is reinterpreted to suggest a spiritual exchange where a ransom or substitute is provided to negative forces instead of the person. | Cf. Psalms — The verse 'The wild donkeys quench their thirst' is from Psalms 104:11. In its original context, it refers to God's provision for wild animals, but in the Zohar and Ma'avar Yabok, it is reinterpreted to describe how lower spiritual entities receive divine influx. | Cf. Zohar on the Cosmic Rooster — The celestial rooster (תרנגולא) appears in multiple Zohar passages as a spiritual entity that announces the changing cosmic times. This parallel helps explain how the author of Ma'avar Yabok is using this symbol to represent the spiritual mechanisms that govern the transitions between different time periods, both cosmic and daily.

רבוא שרשי נשמות של ישראל
שמתחלקים לשבעים רבוא
דיוקנאות. והגם כי הם רבים
יותר כל אחד יונק מדיוקן שלו.
ואם איש אחד מקלקל ופוגם. אז
האות שלו אותה שנשמתו יונקת
ממנו היא פגומה. וכאילו היא
חסרה בתורה ח״ו[i] ונמצא שמטיל
מום בקדשי תורתנו הקדושה
ונדחה משם עם מומו שכל אשר
בו מום לא יקרב. והמזכך עצמו
זוכה לראות עולמו בחייו. ויזהר
לבל יטמטם עצמו באכול כל
תועבה כנזכר למעלה. ועיין
בראשית חכמה פרק ט״ו משער
הקדושה פגם האכילה. ושם בפ׳
ט״ז וי״ז הפליא לדבר מקדושת
הזווג שגם הוא הכנה גדולה
לקדושה. ואין לך דבר שירמוז
בו בעה״ז דרך יחוד וזווג עליון
כמוהו. ואנו עתידים לבאר כי
המות היא מחסדי הבורא עלינו
ואמר ר״ש בן יוחאי באדרת
האזינו[ii] אסהדנא עלי דכל יומאי
דקאימנא תאיבנא למיחמי יומא
דא ולא סליק ברעותא דהא
בעטרא דא מתעטרא האי יומא.
ועיין בזה בראשית חכמה בשער
אהבה פרק ו׳ ושם פירשו למה
הצדיקים במיתתן קרויים איים.

six hundred thousand root souls of Israel,[1] which are divided into seventy myriads of forms.[A] Although there are actually many more, each one draws sustenance from its own form. If one person corrupts and damages, then the letter from which his soul draws sustenance becomes flawed. It is as if that letter is missing from the Torah, God forbid, thus casting a blemish upon the holiness of our sacred Torah, and he is rejected from there with his blemish, for "whoever has a blemish shall not approach." One who purifies himself merits to see his [spiritual] world during his lifetime.[2] He should be careful not to dull his senses by consuming abominations, as mentioned above. See Reshit Chochmah, chapter 15 of the Gate of Holiness regarding the damage caused by improper eating. And there in chapters 16 and 17, he speaks wonderfully about the sanctity of marital union, which is also a great preparation for holiness. There is nothing in this world that symbolizes the path of unification and supernal coupling as well as this. We will explain later that death is one of the Creator's kindnesses to us, and Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai said in the Idra of Ha'azinu:[B] "I testify that throughout all my days I have yearned to see this day, but it did not arise in my will, for on this day I am crowned with this crown." See more on this in Reshit Chochmah, in the Gate of Love, chapter 6, where they explain why the righteous in their death are called "islands."[3] And in chapter 9, they explain the secret of the soul's garments. The reason why

5R 10R 15R 20R 25R 30R

'600,000' might be clearer in a modern English translation, especially when dealing with specific quantities.

[B]Or: "70 myriads of soul-images" — The term 'דיוקנאות' (dyoknaot) specifically refers to spiritual images or forms of the soul in kabbalistic literature. This alternate translation preserves the mystical connotation more precisely.

[C]Or: "in the Idra Zuta (the Lesser Assembly)" — The 'Idra of Ha'azinu' refers specifically to the Idra Zuta, which appears in the Zohar portion of Ha'azinu. Using the more commonly recognized term might help readers familiar with kabbalistic literature.

[1]This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that the Torah contains 600,000 letters corresponding to the 600,000 root souls of Israel who stood at Mount Sinai (though the actual count of letters in the Torah is closer to 304,805). This concept appears in many mystical works including the Megaleh Amukot by Rabbi Nathan Nata Spira.

[2]The phrase 'to see one's world during one's lifetime' (לראות עולמו בחייו) refers to experiencing spiritual illumination or divine revelation in this world, rather than having to wait for the afterlife.

[1]This unusual metaphor of the righteous as 'islands' (איים) after death appears in rabbinic literature

[i]The Hebrew abbreviation 'ח״ו' stands for 'chas v'shalom' (God forbid), indicating the gravity of causing a flaw in the Torah through one's sins.

[ii]R"Sh refers to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, the traditional author of the Zohar. The Idra of Ha'azinu (also known as Idra Zuta or Lesser Assembly) is a section of the Zohar where Rabbi Shimon delivered his final teachings before his death.

ובפרק ט׳ פירשו סוד המלבושים לנפש אדם. וטעם למה מיכאל מקריב נשמותיהם של ישראל שם בפ׳ ראשון. ואמרו חז״ל שאליהו מקריב בבית המקדש ממש השני תמידין וכותב על עורות הקרבנות מעשיהם וזכיותיהם של ישראל וזוהי כונת ואשי ישראל ותפלתם.[i] כי לפי שקטרג עליהם עתה בא לתקן והוא כותב המצות שאדם עושה אפי׳ בקצה הארץ. והאזור שהיה לבוש אפשר כי היה מעורו של איל של עקדת יצחק כדי להזכיר זכות אבות לעולם. ובפ׳ ויקהל דף קס״ט תוכחה על הזהרת האדם לתקון מעשיו ונשמתו מיונה שירד לירכתי הספינה. ופי׳ שלשה שלוחים העומדים עליו בעת מותו. ודין הנפש והגוף והשבעה עידנין דיחלפון עלוהי ע״כ ברכי נפשי את ה׳ עד לא תיפוק מהאי עלמא. צריך ליזהר שלא לזוז הגוסס ממקומו אפי׳ אם אומר שאינו יכול להפרד שם. ואם יראים מדליקה יזיזוהו. והחי לעולם קודם להצלת המת. ואין עושין שום מעשה לגרום למת שימות במהרה כגון מפתחות בית הכנסת וכדומה. אך מסירים המונע כגון אם יש חומב עצים שם בשבונה, דלחיי שעה חיישינן דיש קונה עולמו בשעה וברגע אחד בהרהורי תשובה. ועוד יש טעם נעלם בזה. ועיין מזה בהגה״ה י״ד

Michael offers the souls of Israel is explained there in the first chapter. Our Sages taught that Elijah offers the two daily sacrifices in the actual Temple and records the deeds and merits of Israel on the hides of the sacrifices. This is the meaning of "the fire-offerings of Israel and their prayer." Because he once accused them, he now comes to rectify, and he records the commandments that a person performs even at the edge of the earth. The belt he wore was possibly from the hide of the ram of Isaac's binding, to eternally invoke the merit of the forefathers. In Parshat Vayakhel, page 169, there is a rebuke concerning the warning for man to rectify his deeds and his soul, [learning] from Jonah who descended to the depths of the ship. It explains the three messengers who stand over a person at the time of his death, the judgment of the soul and the body, and the seven periods that will pass over him. Therefore, "Bless the Lord, O my soul," before you depart from this world. One must be careful not to move a dying person from his place, even if he says he cannot separate [from his soul] there. If there is fear of fire, they may move him. The living always take precedence over saving the dead. One should not perform any action to cause the dying person to die quickly, such as [removing] synagogue keys and the like. However, one may remove obstacles, such as if there is a woodchopper in the neighborhood, for we are concerned for even momentary life,[1] as one may acquire his eternal world in a single hour or moment through thoughts of repentance.[2] There is also a hidden reason for this. See more on this in the Hagahot Yoreh Deah, section 339. One should not give food to a dying person because he cannot swallow, but one may place in his mouth water squeezed from an herb that has been crushed, as written in Sefer Hasidim. One

and is elaborated in kabbalistic texts. It suggests that like islands that remain visible above water while their foundations extend deep below, the righteous remain spiritually influential in this world even after death.

[2]The Hebrew term 'חיי שעה' (momentary life) is a technical halakhic concept emphasizing that even a brief extension of life is considered valuable in Jewish law, which is why actions that might hasten death are forbidden.

[3]This reflects the rabbinic teaching that 'there are those who acquire their world in a single moment' (יש קונה עולמו בשעה אחת), emphasizing the power of sincere repentance even at the very end of life.

[i]This phrase comes from the Jewish liturgy of the Amidah prayer, asking God to accept favorably the fire-offerings of Israel and their prayers. The author interprets this as referring to Elijah recording the spiritual merits of Israel.

סי׳ של״ט.[i] ואין נותנין לגוסס
לאכול כי אינו יכול לבלוע
אבל נותנין בפיו מים שמוצצין
מן עשב אחד שכתשוהו וימיצו
המרק ממנו כמו שכתוב בספר
החסידים. ואין זועקים עליו
בשעת יציאת נשמה שתשוב נפשו
כי אינו יכול לחיות אלא מעט
ימים ואותן ימים יסבול יסורים
קשים וזהו עת למות שהוא בי״ד
עתים לרעה בקהלת.[ii] ואין
לבן ליתן לאב דברים המזיקים
לו בחליו גם כי ישאלם בגיזום
רב:[iii]

should not cry out during the departure of the soul that his soul should return, because he would only be able to live a few more days, and during those days he would suffer severe pain. This is "a time to die," which is one of the fourteen negative times mentioned in Ecclesiastes.[A] A son should not give his father things harmful to him in his illness, even if he demands them forcefully.

ובספר החסידים סי׳ רל״ז יש
תקון למי שבא לו מת בחלום
ואמר לו שילך עמו והוא הבטיח
לו על זה. ואמרו כי פעמים
בא המת לחי בחלום להשיבו
בתשובה. וטעם מנהגן של הרבה
מקומות לפתוח חלונות במקום
שיש גוסס בר מינן הוא כי השדים
וכחות מלאך המות וגם הוא

In the Sefer Hasidim, section 237, there is a remedy for someone who has been visited by a dead person in a dream who asked him to accompany him, and he promised to do so. They say that sometimes the dead come to the living in dreams to guide them to repentance.

The reason for the custom in many places to open windows where there is a dying person (God forbid[B])[1] is because demons and the forces of the

[A] Or: ""a time to die" from Ecclesiastes 3:2, which is one of the fourteen times mentioned there" — Adding the biblical reference makes it clearer for readers, and not all of the times in Ecclesiastes 3 are necessarily 'negative'—they are simply appropriate times for different activities.

[A] Or: "may it not happen to us" — A more literal translation of the Aramaic phrase which serves as an apotropaic formula (warding off evil) when mentioning death or dying. This translation better preserves the distancing function of the original expression.

[1] The Hebrew expression 'bar minan' (literally 'outside from us') is an apotropaic formula used

[i] This refers to annotations or glosses on the Yoreh De'ah section of the Shulchan Aruch (the code of Jewish law), specifically section 339 which deals with laws concerning the dying.

[ii] This refers to Ecclesiastes 3:1-8, which lists fourteen pairs of contrasting times, including "a time to be born and a time to die." The author interprets these as including fourteen negative or difficult times.

[iii] Cf. Reshit Chochmah — The text explicitly cites Reshit Chochmah (Beginning of Wisdom), a major kabbalistic ethical work by Rabbi Eliyahu de Vidas (16th century). The specific reference to chapters on eating and marital union indicates the author is drawing on established kabbalistic teachings about physical practices that affect spiritual purity. | Cf. Idra of Ha'azinu — The quote from Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai comes from the Idra Zuta (Lesser Assembly), a section of the Zohar appearing in Parashat Ha'azinu that describes Rabbi Shimon's final teachings before his death. The author quotes this to support the view that death can be seen as a divine kindness rather than merely a punishment. | Cf. Sefer Hasidim — Sefer Hasidim (Book of the Pious) by Rabbi Judah the Pious (12th-13th century) is cited as a halakhic source for practical care of the dying. This reference shows how Ma'avar Yabok integrates mystical concepts with practical halakhic guidance. | Cf. Hagahot Yoreh Deah — The reference to Yoreh Deah (a section of the Shulchan Aruch dealing with laws of life and death) shows the author's commitment to grounding mystical practices in established halakhic frameworks, particularly for end-of-life care. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 3:2 — The reference to "a time to die" alludes to Ecclesiastes 3:1-8, which lists fourteen pairs of contrasting times. The author uses this biblical source to frame the concept of death as a divinely ordained appropriate time rather than merely a tragedy.

בעצמו אינו יכול לילך רק דרך
המקום הנגזר להם. ואין להם
רשות לנטות לא על ימין ולא
על שמאל. וראיה מפרק כל
הבשר שהשד היה עומד תחת
המרזב ושבר החבית שהניחו לו
על אזניו והיה זה לפי שלא ניתן
לו רשות לזוז משם. ובפ׳ ערבי
פסחים אמרי׳ כי אין הלובו
רק בצדי רשות הרבים. ולכן
כשהאדם מפחד פעמים שנכנס
למקום ששם השד. ואמרו מאי
תקנתיה לינשוף מדוכתיה תלתא
גרמידי. ולכן סכנה לסתום
חלונות ופתחים שמא נכנס בפתח
או בחלון אחד ואולי עתיד
לצאת דרך שם ואם יסתמנו
מטריח המזיק לילך בדרך אחר
ואין להתגרות בשטן במעשה
דרבי פלימו דהוה רגיל לומר
גירא בעינא דשמנא[i] ואתחזי ליה
וצעריה. ולכן ותלחץ רגל בלעם
אל הקיר לעבור במקום הנגזר
לו. ויש כחות מתחברים תשעה
תשעה יחד ולכן אמרו כי יש
תשעה עלים בענף אילן אגוזים
ראשו של זה בצד עקרו של זה
וג״כ אנשי היער מתחברים תשעה
יחד. והם הפראים. ולכן אמרו
כי בדורות הראשונים לא יאכל
אדם תרי וישתה תרי[ii] כי מתגרה
בהם ואולי זהו אחד מן הטעמים

Angel of Death, and even the Angel himself, can only travel along paths designated for them. They have no permission to deviate either to the right or to the left. Evidence for this comes from the chapter "Kol Habasar" where a demon was standing under a gutter and broke a jar that was placed on its ears, because it was not permitted to move from that spot. And in the chapter "Arvei Pesachim" they say that such beings can only travel along the sides of public domains.[A] Therefore, when a person is afraid, sometimes they enter a place where a demon is present. They taught: "What is the remedy? Let him move three cubits from his place." For this reason, it is dangerous to close windows and openings, lest a harmful entity has entered through one door or window and is meant to exit that way. If we close it, we force the harmful entity to find another path, and one should not provoke Satan, as in the case of Rabbi Pelimo who habitually said, "An arrow in Satan's eye!" until Satan appeared to him and tormented him.[B] This is also why "Balaam's donkey pressed his foot against the wall"—to pass through the place decreed for it.

There are forces that combine in groups of nine, which is why they say that there are nine leaves on a branch of a walnut tree, with the head of one next to the root of another, and likewise the forest people gather in groups of nine. These are the "wild ones."[1] Therefore they said that in earlier generations, one should not eat pairs or drink pairs, as this antagonizes these forces. Perhaps this is one of the reasons why a court should not have an even number

[B] Or: "public thoroughfares" — In Jewish law, this term refers specifically to public thoroughfares where many people travel. This translation better conveys the specific legal category being referenced.

[C] Or: "and Satan appeared to him and caused him distress" — This more literal translation of the Aramaic preserves the causal relationship implied in the original text between Rabbi Pelimo's provocative statement and Satan's appearance.

when mentioning death or illness, similar to saying 'God forbid' or 'far be it from us.'

[2] The Hebrew term 'pera'im' literally means 'wild ones' and appears to refer to a category of forest spirits or demons that gather in groups of nine. This relates to the author's explanation of mystical numerical patterns.

[i] This Aramaic phrase means 'an arrow in Satan's eye' and comes from a story in Kiddushin 81a where Rabbi Pelimo would regularly use this phrase until Satan appeared to him as a poor man and tormented him, teaching him a lesson about hubris.

[ii] This refers to the Talmudic superstition against consuming things in pairs (zugot), which was believed to make one vulnerable to harmful spiritual forces. This concept appears in Pesachim 110a-b.

שאין בית דין שקול.[i] מלבד טעם
המזכה והמחייב והמכריע. וכן
הקליפות הם עשתי עשר כי כל
מספר שלהם בלתי שקול. ומכל
מה שנאמר נבין טעם לפתיחת
החלונות שנוהגים. וי״א שהוא
לפנות מקום לנשמה שתלך לאות
נפשה[ii] על דרך וכוין פתיחן ליה
וגו׳ ששם שער עליית הנשמות.
ועוד נוכל לומר שהוא להבריח
הרוחות. ואם הוא לעת בקר
ודאי פתיחת החלונות תהיה
מכוונת מלבד האמור להשליט
מדת החסד שגוברת אז. וכן
נכון לאדם לעשות בכל יום
בבקר קודם עליית השמש לפתוח
חלונות ביתו ויכוין לעשות פתח
ומסלול לחוט של חסד שיכנס
בביתו ובחומותיו כי בזה חסד
אל יהיה בביתו כל היום וההפך
בתחלת הלילה שבו תרמוש
כל חיתו יער יסגור חלונותיו
ויכוין להבדיל בין הקדש ובין
החול עד כי יבא זמן חצות שאז
יחזרו ויתבלעו בנוקבא דתהומא
רבא.[iii] והכל הולך אחר כוונת
הלב שכפי הכוונה כך יפעל

of judges, apart from the need for one who acquits, one who condemns, and one who decides between them. Similarly, the kelipot (shells/negative forces) are eleven in number,[1] for all their numbers are uneven. 120R

From all that has been said, we can understand the reason for the custom of opening windows. Some say it is to make way for the soul to depart according to its desire, as in "and windows were opened for him," which refers to the gate for the ascent of souls. We can also say it is to drive away spirits. And if it is morning time, certainly the opening of windows is intended, besides what has been said, to empower the attribute of Loving-kindness (Chesed) which predominates at that time.[2] 125R 130R

Similarly, it is proper for a person to open the windows of his house every morning before sunrise, with the intention of creating an opening and pathway for the thread of divine kindness to enter his home[3] and its walls, for through this, God's loving-kindness will be in his house all day. Conversely, at the beginning of the night, when "all the beasts of the forest creep about,"[4] he should close his windows with the intention of separating the holy from the profane, until the time of midnight, when these forces will be reabsorbed into the great abyss.[A] Everything follows the intention of the heart,[B] for according to 135R 140R

[A] Or: "into the opening of the great deep" — This more literal translation preserves the gendered metaphor in the original kabbalistic terminology, where 'nukva' (feminine) refers to a receptive cosmic vessel that contains and neutralizes harmful forces.

[A] Or: "depends on the intention of the heart" — This translation better captures the causal relationship expressed in the original, emphasizing that the efficacy of these spiritual practices depends entirely on one's inner intention rather than merely following it.

[1] The concept of 'kelipot' (shells or husks) is central to Lurianic Kabbalah, representing the outer layers that conceal the divine light and are associated with evil or impurity.

[2] In Kabbalistic thought, different times of day are associated with different divine attributes (sefirot). Morning is associated with Chesed (Loving-kindness), which is why opening windows at dawn has particular spiritual significance.

[3] The 'thread of kindness' (chut shel chesed) is a kabbalistic concept referring to the flow of divine mercy and blessing that can be channeled into the physical world through proper intention and action.

[4] This is a direct quote from Psalm 104:20 that is being used metaphorically to refer to harmful spiritual forces that become active at night.

[i] Jewish courts traditionally have an odd number of judges to prevent deadlock. Here the author adds a mystical dimension to this practical rule, connecting it to cosmic numerical patterns.

[ii] This expression suggests that the soul has its own desires or will regarding how it departs, reflecting the kabbalistic view that the soul retains consciousness and agency during its transition from the body.

[iii] This kabbalistic phrase refers to the 'great abyss' where negative forces are contained or neutralized. At midnight, according to mystical tradition, these forces must return to their source, making it a time particularly favorable for Torah study and prayer.

המעשה. ויתראה למעלה לא
דבר ריק הוא זה למי שגדל על
ברכי החכמים וכל המלעיג צריך
כפרה ודאי:[i][ii]

one's intention, so will the action manifest and be perceived above. 145R

This is not an empty matter for one who has grown up at the knees of the sages, and anyone who mocks this certainly requires atonement.

פרק כ״ז

Chapter 27

סוב נא לך דודי, ופוק חזי
ברעיא מהימנא[iii] פ׳ משפטים
דף קי״ז ע״ב דאמר בכלל דבריו
דאית מלאכין דאינון משמשין
לגופא ומלאכין דמשמשין
לנשמה בגוונא דאית אפרשותא
בין גופא לנשמתא[iv] הכי נמי
אית אפרשותא בין מלאכין
דגופא למלאכין דנשמתא.
ואית נשמתא לנשמתא ומלאכין
למלאכין.[v] ואלין דאינון נשמתא

Go now, my beloved,[1] and observe what is written in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Mishpatim, folio 117b, where it states among its teachings that there are angels who serve the body and angels who serve the soul. Just as there is a distinction between body and soul, so too is there a distinction between the angels of the body and the angels of the soul. And there is a soul for the soul, and angels for angels. And those that are soul to the soul are all one, and although in light they appear as a body in relation to the soul, one to another,[A] just as the soul in relation to the 5R 10R

[A] Or: "and although when illuminated by comparison they are like a body in relation to a soul,

[1] The opening phrase 'סוב נא לך דודי' is a poetic address to the reader in the style of Song of Songs, using terms of endearment common in mystical texts when inviting the reader to contemplate deeper mysteries.

[i] The author concludes with a warning against mockery of these spiritual practices, emphasizing that these are not mere superstitions but profound mystical teachings that should be treated with reverence.

[ii] Cf. Sefer Hasidim — The text references a specific remedy from Sefer Hasidim (a medieval ethical work) for someone who promised to accompany a dead person in a dream, suggesting this was considered a serious spiritual concern requiring formal remedy. | Cf. Talmud — The passage references a Talmudic story about a demon under a gutter to prove that demons can only move along designated paths, supporting the mystical reasoning behind opening windows for the dying. | Cf. Talmud — This Talmudic reference is used to support the idea that demons travel only along the sides of public domains, further developing the conceptual framework for how harmful spiritual entities move through space. | Cf. Rabbi Pelimo and Satan — This reference to Rabbi Pelimo who provoked Satan by saying 'an arrow in Satan's eye' serves as a cautionary tale against deliberately antagonizing spiritual forces. | Cf. Balaam's donkey — The biblical story of Balaam's donkey is reinterpreted through a mystical lens, suggesting that the donkey pressed against the wall specifically to follow the predetermined path decreed for spiritual entities. | Cf. Pairs (zugot) — The text references the Talmudic superstition against consuming items in pairs, contextualizing it as a way to avoid antagonizing groups of harmful spiritual forces that operate in specific numerical patterns. | Cf. Opening of windows in Daniel — The phrase 'windows were opened for him' alludes to Daniel's practice of praying with windows open toward Jerusalem, reinterpreted here as creating pathways for souls to ascend. | Cf. Psalm 104:20 — This biblical verse is used metaphorically to refer to harmful spiritual forces that become active at night, explaining why windows should be closed at this time to separate 'the holy from the profane.'

[iii] Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd) is a section of the Zohar attributed to Moses that contains mystical interpretations of the commandments.

[iv] The text establishes a parallel between the body-soul relationship and the relationship between different types of angels, suggesting that the spiritual world mirrors the structure of human existence.

[v] This describes a hierarchical structure in the spiritual world where souls have higher souls above them, just as angels have higher angels above them, creating a continuous chain of being from humans to the divine.

לנשמתא כולהו חד ואע״ג
דבאורא מתלא אינון בגופא
אצל נשמתא אלין לאלין במה
15 דנשמתא לקבל קוב״ה חשיבא
בגופא. ואית מלאכין דימינא
דתליין מקוב״ה ואלין משמאלא
דתליין בשכינתא. ואלין דתליין
מקוב״ה ושכינתיה ביחודא
20 חדא. ותתאי כולהו רשימין
למעלה. מנהון במלאכי. מנהון
בכרסייא. ומנהון בארבע חיוון
דכורסייא מנהון בככבי ומזלי.
ומנהון רשימין במדורא דקוב״ה.
25 מדברים אלו יהיה לנו ראיה
שלכל אדם יש לו מלאך מזלו
ברקיע[i] ועליה אמר רבנן מזליה
[ii] חזי.

Holy One, blessed be He, is considered like a body. And there are angels of the right that depend on the Holy One, blessed be He, and those of the left that depend on the Shekhinah. And those that depend 15R
on the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shekhinah in a single unity. And all those below are inscribed above—some among the angels, some in the Throne, some in the four Beasts of the Throne, some in the stars and constellations, and some are inscribed in 20R
the dwelling place of the Holy One, blessed be He. From these words we have proof that every person has his guardian angel in the firmament,[A] concerning which our Sages said, "his mazal [fortune/guardian angel] sees."[1] 25R

עוד ידוע כי ע״י רל״א
30 שערים[iii] היוצאים מכ״ב אלפא

It is further known that through the 231 gates[2] formed from the 22 letters of the alpha-

these compared to those" — This alternate rendering of this difficult phrase captures the sense of hierarchical comparison being made, emphasizing that higher spiritual entities relate to lower ones in the same way souls relate to bodies.

[B]Or: "From these statements we have evidence that each person has an angelic representative of their destiny in the heavens" — This alternate translation emphasizes the concept of mazal as destiny or fortune rather than strictly as a guardian angel, which captures an additional nuance of the Hebrew term 'מזלו' that encompasses both protective and deterministic aspects.

[1]The phrase 'מזליה חזי' (his mazal sees) appears in Talmudic literature (Megillah 3a) to explain supernatural awareness. Here it is reinterpreted in a kabbalistic context to mean that each person has a celestial representative that 'sees' or knows things beyond human perception.

[1]The original phrase 'רל״א שערים' (231 gates) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the number of possible paired combinations of the 22 Hebrew letters. This is a fundamental concept in Jewish mystical cosmology, particularly in the Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation).

[ii]This concept of a personal guardian angel or celestial representative (mazal) for each individual is central to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of how divine providence operates during life, illness, and death.

[iii]Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — The author quotes from Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd), a section of the Zohar attributed to Moses, to establish the existence of different types of angels serving different aspects of human existence. This text serves as an authoritative source for the kabbalistic understanding of the spiritual hierarchy that governs human souls. | Cf. Zohar — The passage employs the typical style and terminology of the Zohar, particularly its discussion of spiritual hierarchies, the relationship between body and soul, and the connections between human souls and angelic beings. This reference establishes the author's understanding within the mainstream of kabbalistic thought. | Cf. Talmudic concept of mazal — The final line references the Talmudic concept that 'mazal sees' (mazlei chazi), suggesting that each person has a celestial representative or fortune that influences their life. The author integrates this earlier rabbinic concept with the more elaborate kabbalistic angelology to suggest that these traditional Jewish concepts have deeper mystical significance.

[i]The '231 gates' refers to the mathematical number of possible paired combinations of the 22 Hebrew letters (calculated as $22 \times 21 \div 2 = 231$). In Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), these combinations are understood as the channels through which divine creative energy flows into the world.

ביתא נברא כל יש. לכן החיה
העליונה נקראת ישראל.[i] ירצה
מוציאה כל היש ע״י רל״א
שערים. וכל זה נקרא מקום שכל
אומין המדות עליונים משפיעים
למלכות שהיא כלל הכל ואח״כ
נבראו הגלגלים שע״י כדוריותם
וסיבובם יתחברו ויתגלגלו
ד׳ יסודות[ii] תחתונים יחד
ומתגלגלים הויתן. וכאשר יעברו
לפני בעל השפע מקבלים כפי
הרצון העליון. ואחר קבלתם
יריצו אורם למקום אשר יושלחו
עד תקופתם להביא הצורה.
הן בריות הן פירות הן מזונות.
ואמרו כי הגלגלים הם כמנין
השמים הממונים להביא. ויש
גלגל המתגלגל פעם אחת ביום.
ויש פעם בחדש. ויש לה׳ שנים.
ויש לי׳. ויש לק׳. ויש לאלף.
ויש לכמה אלפים. יש ממזרח
למערב. ויש בהפך. וכן מצפון
לדרום ומאלכסון לאלכסון.
ובתוכם שם היכולת הגדול.
ובזה נכון הוא לבא השפע
מכל צד ברצון בעל השפעים
כלם. וכל הנשמות חקוקות
ביריעה לפני בסא הכבוד ויש
קוראים אותו חשמ״ל[iii] וי״א

bet, all existence was created. Thus, the supernal creature is called "Israel,"[1] meaning that it brings forth all existence through these 231 gates. All this is called "place," where all the power of the supernal attributes flows down to Malkhut (Kingdom),[A] which encompasses everything. Afterward, the celestial spheres were created, which through their spherical nature and rotation cause the four lower elements to combine and revolve together, cycling through their various forms. When they pass before the Master of Divine Flow,[2] they receive according to the supernal will. After receiving this influence, they direct their light to the place where they are sent until their appointed time to bring forth form—whether creatures, fruits, or sustenance.

It is said that the number of celestial spheres corresponds to the number of heavens appointed to bring [divine influence]. There is a sphere that rotates once a day, another once a month, another every five years, another every ten years, another every hundred years, another every thousand years, and yet another every several thousand years. Some rotate from east to west, others in the opposite direction, and likewise from north to south and from diagonal to diagonal. Within them is placed the great power, and through this arrangement, divine flow properly comes from every direction according to the will of the Master of all flows.

All souls are engraved on a curtain before the

[A] Or: "All this is called "Place" (Makom), where all the strength of the supernal qualities flows into Malkhut" — This alternate translation preserves 'Makom' as a technical term, which in kabbalah often refers to God Himself (as in 'HaMakom'), and renders 'middot' as 'qualities' rather than 'attributes', which might be more accessible to some readers.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'החיה העליונה נקראת ישראל' refers to a kabbalistic entity, not the nation of Israel. In this context, 'Israel' functions as a cosmic archetype representing the divine creative force.
[3] The Hebrew 'בעל השפע' literally means 'master of the flow,' referring to God as the source of all divine influence that cascades down through the various spiritual levels.

[ii] The term 'the supernal creature is called Israel' refers to a kabbalistic concept where 'Israel' represents a cosmic entity responsible for bringing forth existence, not merely the historical people of Israel. This interpretation draws on the etymology of Israel (ישראל) as containing the letters that spell 'li rosh' (לי ראש, 'to me is the head'), suggesting primacy in creation.
[iii] This refers to the classical Aristotelian-medieval cosmology that posited four elements (earth, water, air, and fire) that combine in different proportions to create all physical existence. The celestial spheres' movements were believed to influence these combinations.
[i] The term 'Chashmal' appears in Ezekiel's vision (Ezekiel 1:4) and is variously translated as 'amber,' 'electrum,' or 'hashmal.' In Kabbalah, it refers to a luminous divine substance that serves as a barrier or interface between the higher and lower realms.

שהוא פרגוד.[i] וזהו עד שיכלו כל הנשמות שבגוף[ii] ובעת עלות הרצון לפניו יתׄ להביא נשמה לעולם קורא למלאך הממונה שהוא רוח והרוח בא בגלגל ומניעו. ובזה ימצא שכל פעולות המלאכים למטה יתהוו ע״י גלגל. ובזה נמצא מלאך וגלגל ורוח הכל דבר אחד מיוחדים. וכאשר יהיה האופן בתוך האופן[iii] כן יהיה מלאך בתוך מלאך וגלגל בתוך גלגל[iv]

Throne of Glory,[B] which some call Chashmal,[3] while others say it is the Pargod (celestial curtain). This is what is meant by "until all the souls in the body are exhausted."[A] When the divine will rises before the Blessed One to bring a soul into the world, He calls to the appointed angel, which is a spirit, and that spirit enters a sphere and moves it.[B] Thus we find that all the actions of angels below occur through a celestial sphere. In this way, we understand that angel, sphere, and spirit are all one unified reality. Just as there is "a wheel within a wheel,"[1] so too there is an angel within an angel and a sphere within a sphere.

[A] Or: "inscribed on a parchment before the Throne of Glory" — The Hebrew word 'yeriah' can refer to either a curtain or a parchment/scroll. The alternate translation emphasizes the idea of souls being written or recorded rather than physically engraved, which might better align with the imagery of a celestial book of souls.

[B] Or: "until all the souls in the celestial treasury called 'Guf' are depleted" — This alternate translation clarifies that 'Guf' is not referring to a physical body but to the rabbinic concept of a celestial treasury of souls. This is more explicit and helps avoid confusion for readers unfamiliar with this concept.

[C] Or: "He summons the appointed angel, which is a spiritual force, and this spirit enters into a celestial sphere and sets it in motion" — This alternate translation emphasizes the active nature of the divine summons and clarifies that 'ruach' in this context refers to a spiritual force rather than just 'spirit', which might have different connotations in English.

[1] The term 'חשמ״ל' (Chashmal) appears in Ezekiel's vision and is a complex mystical concept that has been variously interpreted. I've left it untranslated as it is a technical term with no precise English equivalent.

[2] This is a direct reference to Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah) in Ezekiel 1:16, which became central to early Jewish mysticism. The nested wheels represent the complex, hierarchical structure of the spiritual realms.

[i] The 'Pargod' (celestial curtain) is described in rabbinic literature as a metaphysical barrier behind which God's glory resides. In the Talmud (Berakhot 18b), the souls of the dead are said to be behind this curtain, able to observe events in our world.

[iii] This refers to the rabbinic concept of 'guf' (body), a celestial treasury where all souls destined to be born are stored. According to tradition, the Messiah will not come until this treasury is emptied (Yevamot 62a).

[iv] This phrase directly quotes Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Ezekiel 1:16), where wheels within wheels represent the complex, interlocking nature of divine providence and celestial mechanics.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage relates to Ma'avar Yabok's larger discussion of the soul's celestial origins and the mechanism by which souls descend to earth, which is relevant to understanding how the soul experiences death as a return journey through these same celestial spheres. | Cf. Zohar — The concept of the 231 gates (רל״א שערים) appears in several kabbalistic works including the Zohar, which discusses how these permutations of Hebrew letters serve as channels through which divine creative energy flows into the world. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The 231 gates (רל״א שערים) is a direct reference to Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), one of the earliest extant kabbalistic texts, which describes how God created the world through 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet and their 231 possible paired combinations. | Cf. Ezekiel — The phrase 'wheel within a wheel' (האופן בתוך האופן) is drawn from Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah), which Ma'avar Yabok uses as a metaphor for the nested hierarchical structure of spiritual realms. | Cf. Talmud Bavli — The phrase 'until all the souls in the body are exhausted' refers to the Talmudic teaching that the Messiah will not come until all souls stored in the celestial treasury (called 'guf' or body) have been born into the world.

נמצא שהמלאך בגלגל ומקבל
שפע שמה ומגלגל בימים קצובים.
וכנויי הממונה אם לזכר אם
לנקבה. ובאותו גלגל ותנועה
שהיה במעי אמו מביאו לעולם
בכח כל יכול. ואותו קבול
שפע מקבלת הנשמה. וזהו
אמרם ז״ל כל אדם יש לו מזל
וכוכב למעלה[i] הקבועים בגלגלי
התכונה כל אחד כפי דרכו.
ועתה אם הנשמה הנוצרת נשפעת
בשעה שהתחיל הגלגל להתגלגל
והיא מאותן המתגלגלין פעם
אחת ביום. בו ביום ימות ואם
יתגלגל לי׳ שנים אז תהיה מיתתו.
ואם לע׳ אז יסוף ואם למאה
ק׳ שנים יחיה. עד שוב הגלגל
המחבר בתנועה ההיא. וכל
ימי חייו יתגלגל עמו הוא הרוח
היוצא ונכנס באפיו בכח הבורא.
והוא המעמיד החומר בסוד
וברוח פיו כל צבאם. כי כשאין
לו להשיב רוחו ולהוציא רוחו
הוא מת. והפירות מתקטנים בכל
דור כן הבריות מתחלשים[ii] שגם
שהגלגלים רוחניים הם מ״מ
בהתגלגלם יחלשו שכל מחובר
יש לו גבול ומתחלש עד שעתיד

Thus, the angel is in the celestial sphere,[2] receiving divine influence there and revolving in appointed times. The name of the appointed [angel] may be masculine or feminine. And in that same sphere and motion that existed when [the soul] was in its mother's womb, it brings it into the world through the power of the Almighty.[1] And the soul receives that same flow of divine influence. This is what our Sages of blessed memory meant when they said that every person has a mazal and star above,[A] fixed in the celestial spheres,[B] each according to its way. Now, if the created soul receives its divine flow at the hour when the celestial sphere begins to revolve, and it is among those that revolve once a day, then on that very day it will die. If [its sphere] revolves for ten years, then that will be the time of its death. If [it revolves] for seventy [years], then it will end then, and if for one hundred, it will live one hundred years—until the connecting sphere returns to that same motion. Throughout all the days of its life, the spirit that goes out and enters through its nostrils by the Creator's power revolves with it. And this is what sustains the physical form,[2] according to the secret of "and by the breath of His mouth all their host." For when one cannot return his breath and expel his breath, he dies. And just as fruits become smaller in each generation, so too living beings become weaker, for although the celestial spheres

[A] Or: "every person has a celestial fortune and star above" — The term 'mazal' has multiple meanings including luck, fortune, destiny, and celestial influence. While I kept the Hebrew term 'mazal' in the main translation because it's a technical term in Jewish mysticism, this alternative makes the celestial influence aspect more explicit for readers unfamiliar with the term.

[B] Or: "established in the astrological configurations" — The term 'galgalei ha-techunah' might refer more specifically to astrological configurations rather than celestial spheres in general, so this alternative might be more precise in contexts focusing on astrological correspondences.

[1] The original text doesn't explicitly state 'the angel is in' but begins with 'it is found that,' a common Hebrew rhetorical device indicating a conclusion. I've rendered it more directly in English to maintain the flow of the argument.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'koach kol yachol' literally means 'power of all-capable,' a circumlocution for God that emphasizes divine omnipotence without using the divine name.

[3] The phrase 'b'sod' (literally 'in the secret of') is a common kabbalistic formula introducing an esoteric interpretation of a biblical verse. I've rendered it as 'according to the secret of' to maintain this technical aspect of the text.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that each human soul has a corresponding celestial entity that influences its destiny. The term 'mazal' here doesn't simply mean 'luck' as in modern Hebrew, but refers to a specific astral influence or guardian angel that governs one's spiritual and physical life cycle.

[i] This references a Talmudic concept (found in treatises like Shabbat 112b) that earlier generations were physically and spiritually greater than later ones, with both human beings and natural products gradually diminishing in size and strength throughout cosmic history.

להתפרק כמ״ש ושמים כעשן נמלחו. הנה מזה שלכל אדם יש לו מלאך מזלו וגלגלו ברקיע. ואמרו שפסוק בצלמנו כדמותנו[i] מורה על זה. [ii]

are spiritual, nevertheless, in their revolutions they weaken,[C] since everything that is composite has a limit and weakens until it is destined to come apart, as it is written, "and the heavens shall be dissolved like smoke." From this we see that every person has an angel, his mazal and his sphere in the firmament. And they said that the verse "in Our image, after Our likeness" indicates this. 100R 105R

שכל אדם יש לו מזל בגלגל המזלות מושפע מן המלאך המניעו והמלאך נאצל מכבוד שכינה וזהו בצלמנו כדמותנו כדכתיב ועל הכסא דמות כמראה אדם עליו מלמעלה. וכן אמרו אדם בפני שכינה כקוף בפני אדם.[iii] עוד מתבאר זה מדברי התקונים דף ע״ב ע״ב דאמר והמשכילים יזהירו אלין ד׳ יסודין דגופא יזהירו בהון ד׳ חיוון אינון מזל אריה. מזל שור.

Every person has a mazal in the celestial sphere of constellations,[1] influenced by the angel that moves it, and the angel emanates from the glory of the Divine Presence.[2] This is the meaning of "in Our image, after Our likeness," as it is written: "And upon the throne was the likeness as the appearance of a man above upon it" (Ezekiel 1:26). And thus they said, "A human before the Divine Presence is like a monkey before a human." This is further explained in Tikkunei Zohar (page 72b), which states: "And the wise shall shine"—these are the four elements of the body, within which shine the four ce- 110R 115R

[A] Or: "as they cycle they grow weaker" — The Hebrew term 'hitgalgel' literally refers to rolling or cycling, so this alternative more directly captures the cyclical nature implied in the original, which might be preferable in contexts emphasizing the cosmic cycles rather than mechanical revolution.

[1] The concept of 'mazal' here goes beyond the common understanding of 'luck' to mean a specific celestial counterpart or spiritual destiny connected to each individual soul.

[2] This establishes a chain of emanation: from God's Presence to angels to celestial bodies to human souls, illustrating the kabbalistic principle that all existence flows from divine sources.

[ii] The author offers a mystical interpretation of Genesis 1:26, suggesting that what makes humans 'in God's image' includes having a corresponding celestial counterpart in the heavens. This expands the traditional understanding of divine image to include this cosmic correspondence between earthly beings and celestial forces.

[iii] Cf. Zohar — This passage draws on Zoharic cosmology, particularly from Pekudei, which discusses how celestial powers govern human lifespans and how angelic forces administer the flow of divine energy to human souls. The description of souls receiving influence through celestial spheres directly parallels Zoharic teachings about the mechanisms of divine providence. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The concept of celestial spheres and their correspondence to human lifespans echoes Sefer Yetzirah's system of cosmic correspondences between celestial bodies, time cycles, and human anatomy. The text adopts this framework to explain the predetermination of human lifespan through celestial mechanics. | Cf. Bereishit (Genesis) 1:26 — The text explicitly cites this verse to suggest that humans having a corresponding mazal and star in the heavens is part of what it means to be created in God's image. This kabbalistic interpretation extends the biblical notion of divine image to include a celestial counterpart that governs one's destiny. | Cf. Psalms 33:6 — The text quotes this verse to explain the mechanism by which divine breath sustains physical existence, drawing a parallel between cosmic creation and individual human life, suggesting that the same divine breath that creates celestial bodies also animates human bodies. | Cf. Isaiah 51:6 — This verse is cited to support the idea that even celestial entities have finite lifespans and will eventually disintegrate, reinforcing the text's argument that all composite beings, including celestial spheres, gradually weaken over cosmic time cycles.

[i] This statement compares the relative standing of humans before God to that of monkeys before humans, emphasizing the vast ontological gap between human and divine realms.

מזל נשר. מזל אדם.[iv] בפרצופא
דב״נ אשתמודעאן בהון באנפוי
דב״נ ודא הוא הכרת פניהם
120 ענתה בם. כזוהר. דא נשמתא.
ומצדיקי הרבים באברי דגופא
יהון נהרין מזלייהו ככוכבים
לעולם ועד. ואמרו עוד שם שכל
צדיק יש לו כוכב וכל כוכב
125 נקרא עולם בפני עצמו וכוכב
עם ד׳ אותיותיו בגימטריא
ב״ן[i] במספר שם מלוי החי״ן
שבמלה שהוא פי הגבורה. והוא
מושפע משם זה מכח המלכות
130 המנהלת התחתונים. ואמר
מורי כי התורה נתנה לסוף נ״ב
יום[ii] לרמז שם ב״ן שבמלכות.
ועוד שרצה הקב״ה לחוג בעצמו
ובכבודו י״ט שני של גליות כיון
135 שנתנה תורה בח״ל. וכל ספירה
נקראת עולם ומלכות בפרט
נקרא עוה״ז. ועל זה אמרו כל
צדיק יש לו עולם בפני עצמו
וזהו ומצדיקי הרבים ככוכבים.
140 ובויקרא רבה פ׳ כ״ז אמרו כל
צדיק יש לו עדן בפני עצמו
דכתיב ונחל עדניך בלשון רבים.
וכל הזוכה להלכ׳ אחת יורש
עולם חד כ״ש דזכי למתיבתא.
145 או לשנים או לסתרי תור׳. ואמר
בדף ע״ד כי ציורא דהיכל גנוז
שבג״ע מצוייר בנקודין דאינון
כוכביא דנהרין מרקיעא ובהון
מצויירין נשמתין ורוחין ונפשין

lestial creatures:[3] the mazal of Lion, the mazal of Ox, the mazal of Eagle, and the mazal of Man. In the countenance of a person, they are recognized in 120R
his facial features, and this is "the appearance of their faces testifies against them" (Isaiah 3:9). "Like the brightness of the firmament"—this refers to the soul. "And those who lead many to righteousness" through the limbs of the body, their mazal will shine 125R
"like the stars forever and ever" (Daniel 12:3). It is further stated there that every righteous person has a star, and each star is called a world unto itself.[1] The word "star" (כוכב) with its four letters equals 52 in gematria, corresponding to the Divine 130R
Name Ban (ב״ן) when spelled out with heis, which is the mouth of Gevurah[2] (Strength). It is influenced by this name through the power of Malkhut (Kingdom) which governs the lower realms. And my teacher said that the Torah was given after 52 days 135R
to allude to the name Ban (ב״ן) in Malkhut. Furthermore, the Holy One, blessed be He, wanted to celebrate in His own glory the second day of festivals in the diaspora,[3] since the Torah was given outside the Land of Israel. Each sefirah is called a world, and 140R
Malkhut in particular is called "this world." Based on this, they said that every righteous person has a world unto himself, and this is the meaning of "those who lead many to righteousness [will shine] like the stars." In Vayikra Rabbah (chapter 27), they said 145R
that every righteous person has his own Eden, as it is written: "And You will give them to drink of Your rivers of delights" (Psalm 36:9) in the plural form. Anyone who merits [to understand] a single halakhah inherits one world,[4] how much more so one 150R

[1]This connects human physiology to cosmic structures, following the kabbalistic principle that the human form mirrors divine patterns ('as above, so below').
[2]This suggests that the reward for righteousness includes not just personal salvation but cosmic significance—each righteous person affects an entire realm of existence.
[3]The divine name ב״ן (Ban = 52) is one of the four ways of spelling out the Tetragrammaton. It corresponds to the sefirah of Malkhut and is associated with the material world.
[4]This offers a mystical justification for the second day of festivals observed in the diaspora, suggesting it has divine significance rather than being merely a practical custom.
[1]This reflects the rabbinic teaching that Torah study has cosmic significance, with each halakhah (law) corresponding to an entire world or realm of existence.

[ii]These four mazalot correspond to the four faces of the creatures in Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah), which are foundational symbols in Jewish mysticism.
[iii]The Hebrew word for 'star' (כוכב) has the numerical value of 48. With the four letters themselves (ב,כ,ו,כ) added, the total is 52, corresponding to the divine name ב״ן (Ban).
[iv]The author calculates 52 days from the Exodus to the giving of the Torah, though the traditional count is 50 days (Shavuot). This may include the two additional days Moses added according to rabbinic tradition.

דצדיקייא וציורא דיליה בציורא
דקמץ דאיהו נצוץ רקיע. וממה
שהובא בשבת פ׳ חבית דאמרו
על גרים שגם דאינהו לא הוו
על הר סיני מזלייהו הוה[i] משם
נראה שגם קודם שנולד האדם
יש לו מזל ואולי יהיה בסוד
הדיוקן לנשמות מלשון מזל
הנוזל הנשמה כשם שהצלם קודם
להויות הגופים ודיוקן זה יברא
בעת אצילת נשמתו. ויתהוה
מגולם אויר רוחני שמג״ע עליון
כמו שדרשו על צלם הגוף
וכן אמרו בב׳ המדרגות שעם
האדם שהם כמו מלאכים יצר
טוב ורע שבעת שהנשמה תהיה
נאצלת מזווג עליון בהיכל
לבנת הספיר[ii] גם המלאכים
אלו יהיה נאצלים עמו. והם
מתאבלים ונבדלים ממנו מפני
מעשיו כי יהיו נפגמים במעשיו
להיותם נאצלים עם אצילות
נשמתו. ויצה״ר אז הוא מלאך
קדוש אמנם מרכבתו תהיה
טמאה[iii] שכן דרך כמה מלאכים
קדושים. ומרכבתו תתפשט מד׳
קליפות טמאות שהם עון משחית
אף וחמה והולך לצד שמאלו
של אדם. ויצר הטוב יהיה רוכב
במרכבה הקדושה המתפשטת
מד׳ רגלי המרכבה מהם מיכאל
גבריאל אוריאל רפאל. והולך
לצד ימיצו של אדם[iv] ולא
יתחבר עם האדם רק עד שיהיה

who merits [to enter] the heavenly academy, or [to understand] two [halakhot], or the secrets of Torah. And it states on page 74 that the image of the hidden palace in the Garden of Eden is depicted with points that are like stars shining from the firmament, and within them are depicted the souls, spirits, and vital souls of the righteous. Its form corresponds to the vowel point kamatz, which is a spark of the firmament. From what is brought in Tractate Shabbat in the chapter "The Barrel," where they said about converts that even though they themselves were not present at Mount Sinai, their mazal was there, it appears that even before a person is born, they have a mazal.[1] Perhaps this refers to the secret of the image for souls, deriving from the word mazal meaning "flowing" down to the soul, just as the image precedes the formation of bodies. This image is created at the time of the emanation of one's soul and is formed from a spiritual aerial substance from the supernal Garden of Eden, as they expounded regarding the image of the body. Similarly, they spoke of the two levels accompanying a person, which are like angels—the good and evil inclinations. When the soul is emanated from the supernal union in the Palace of the Sapphire Brick, these angels are also emanated with it. They grieve and separate from the person because of their actions, as they become blemished by the person's deeds, since they were emanated along with the emanation of their soul. The evil inclination is then a holy angel, though its chariot is impure,[2] as is the way with several holy angels. Its chariot extends from the four impure shells, which are Iniquity, Destruction, Anger, and Wrath, and it goes to the left side of the person. The good inclina-

[2]This supports the kabbalistic concept of the pre-existence of souls, suggesting that each person's spiritual destiny or 'mazal' exists before their physical birth.

[1]This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that evil is not a primary existence but a secondary one—even the evil inclination has a holy source but manifests through impure 'vehicles'.

[i]This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 146a) that the souls of future converts were present at Sinai even if they weren't physically born yet, suggesting a pre-existence of souls.

[ii]This describes the kabbalistic concept of souls being created through a divine 'union' in the celestial Palace of the Sapphire Brick, a reference to Exodus 24:10 where the elders saw 'a pavement of sapphire' under God's throne.

[iii]This presents the paradoxical kabbalistic view that even the evil inclination was originally a holy angel, though its 'vehicle' or manifestation became impure. This reflects the concept that evil is not inherently evil in its source but becomes so through its manifestation.

[i]The right side traditionally represents mercy and goodness in Kabbalah, while the left side represents judgment and severity.

בן י״ג שנה ויום אחד.[v] והאדם
185 בכח בחירתו יהיה יכול להכריע
ולהגביר אחד מהצדדין על
חבירו. על דרך הנזכר תחיה
הויות המזל הזה ואם נעלה
הדבר יותר ירמוז למזל עליון
190 הנוזל מכתר. וממנו הויות
הנשמות. ועל ידו מושפעים
באוצר הבנים שהוא ת״ת ע״ד
מ״ש בני חיי ומזוני לאו בזכותא
דאיהו מחסד ולמטה תליין רק
195 במזלא דהיינו כתר[i] ומשם ג״כ
יוכל להיות כי יתהוה מזל פרטי
לכל אדם ברקיע וגם אחר שמת
לעולם מזלו קיים ברקיע וזהו
לא יכרת ולא ישמד שמו מלפני
200 ושם לשון אחיזת שהוא מקום
אחיזת האדם ברקיע ע״ד מ״ש
מה דלא הוה הוה מאי דהוה לא
[iii] [ii] כל שכן:

tion rides in the holy chariot that extends from the 185R
four legs of the Divine Chariot, which are Michael, Gabriel, Uriel, and Raphael, and it goes to the right side of the person. It does not join with the person until they reach the age of thirteen years and one day. Through the power of free choice, a person can tip 190R
the balance and strengthen one side over the other. In the manner described, this mazal comes into being. If we elevate the matter further, it alludes to the supernal mazal that flows from Keter[1] (Crown). From it comes the existence of souls, and through 195R
it they are channeled into the treasury of children, which is Tiferet (Beauty), as it is written: "Children, life, and sustenance do not depend on merit, which is from Chesed (Kindness) and below, but rather on mazal," meaning Keter. From there it is also pos- 200R
sible that an individual mazal is formed for each person in the firmament. Even after death, one's mazal remains forever in the firmament,[2] and this is [the meaning of] "his name shall not be cut off

[2]This connects the concept of individual mazal to the highest divine emanation (Keter/Crown), suggesting that our personal destiny is ultimately rooted in the most transcendent aspect of divinity.
[3]This provides a metaphysical explanation for the continued existence of the soul after death, suggesting that one's spiritual essence or 'mazal' continues to exist in celestial realms.

[ii]This aligns with the traditional Jewish understanding that moral responsibility begins at age 13 for boys (and 12 for girls), when the good inclination fully develops to counter the evil inclination.
[iii]This quotes a Talmudic statement (Moed Katan 28a) that children, life span, and sustenance depend not on merit but on mazal. The author gives this a kabbalistic interpretation, associating mazal with Keter (Crown), the highest divine emanation.
[iv]This philosophical principle means 'that which did not exist now exists; that which already existed, all the more so [continues to exist].' It argues that if God can create something from nothing, surely He can maintain what already exists.
[v]Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 72b — This reference reinforces the author's argument that human beings have cosmic counterparts in the celestial realms, strengthening the idea that each person has a mazal or celestial influence. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:26 — By citing Ezekiel's vision of 'the likeness as the appearance of a man' above the divine throne, the author reinforces the kabbalistic principle that the human form mirrors divine patterns, which justifies the existence of celestial counterparts for human souls. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 27 — This reference supports the author's central argument about individual cosmic significance—just as each righteous person has their own Eden, they also have their own mazal or star. | Cf. Talmud Shabbat, Chapter 'The Barrel' — This reinforces the idea of pre-existence of souls and their connection to spiritual realms before physical birth, supporting the author's argument about mazal existing before birth. | Cf. Daniel 12:3 — This biblical reference provides scriptural support for the kabbalistic concept that righteous humans have celestial counterparts that shine like stars, reinforcing the connection between human virtue and cosmic significance. | Cf. Isaiah 3:9 — This reference supports the kabbalistic idea that physical appearance, particularly facial features, reflects spiritual realities—in this case, the influence of the four celestial creatures on human countenance. | Cf. Psalm 36:9 — This textual detail is used to strengthen the argument that spiritual rewards are individualized, just as mazalot (astrological influences) are individualized. | Cf. Exodus 24:10 — This reference connects the creation of souls to the divine revelation at Sinai, suggesting that the same celestial realm where the elders glimpsed God is where souls are emanated through 'supernal union.' | Cf. Talmud Moed Katan 28a — The author gives this Talmudic statement a kabbalistic interpretation by associating mazal with Keter

nor destroyed from before Me." Here, "name" refers to a connection, which is the place where a person connects to the firmament, as it is said: "What did not exist now exists; what did exist, how much more so [continues to exist]." 205R

פרק כ״ח

Chapter 28

כח מזל זה יעדיף אחר שנולד האדם שמאירו בכח מעשיו וזה יהיה לדעתי אחד מהכוונות שאומרים שהאדם העוסק בתורה בכל יום בורא שמים החדשים וארץ חדשה.[i] כי מוסיף חדוש בכח מזלו עליון ותחתון אשר מציאותו קדום לו כמו שהנשמה קדמה בריאתה לגוף כנודע. ויתוסף לו עוז וחדוה אחר מות האדם כי המזל ימלא מקומו כי מדרך הקדושה להתרבות ולעולם מציאות הראשון נשאר לעד כדאמרו בכמה מציאיות שיש לנשמה מדי רדתה בעה״ז. שבכל מקום נשאר רושם מציאותה בירידה. ועד״ז תהיה בסוד עלייתה וחזרתה לאדוניה. ואמרו בתקונים כי נשמת השבטים היו מסוד המזלות. ופירשו כי מחסד ועד יסוד הם שש ומיסוד עד חסד שש אחרים ומצד המלכות נקראים ז׳ כוכבי לכת מהשכינה עד חסד. וודאי כי כח המזלות מושפע להם מהסדר זמניה עליונים. ועיין עוד מסוד המזל בתקון

The power of this mazal (celestial influence) increases after a person is born, as it is illuminated by the power of their deeds. This, in my opinion, is one of the meanings behind the saying that a person who engages in Torah study daily "creates new heavens and a new earth."[1] For such a person adds innovation to the power of their upper and lower mazal, whose existence preceded them—just as the soul's creation preceded the body, as is known. Strength and joy are added to it after a person's death, for the mazal fills their place, since it is the way of holiness to multiply, and the original existence always remains forever, as they said regarding the various states the soul experiences as it descends to this world. In each place, an impression of its existence remains during its descent. And in this manner it will be in the mystery of its ascent and return to its Master. 5R 10R 15R

They said in the Tikkunim that the souls of the tribes were from the mystery of the constellations.[2] And they explained that from Chesed to Yesod there are six,[3] and from Yesod back to Chesed there are six others, and from the perspective of Malkhut, they are called the seven planets, from the Shekhinah up to Chesed. Certainly, the power of the constellations is influenced by the arrangement of the supernal times. See more about the mystery of mazal in Tikkun 18, page 32. There are also 20R 25R

[1] This phrase refers to Isaiah 65:17 and 66:22. The author is using this biblical concept metaphorically to suggest that Torah study has creative power that transforms both the spiritual cosmos and the person studying.

[2] The Hebrew term "sod ha-mazalot" refers to the kabbalistic concept that the twelve tribes of Israel correspond to the twelve zodiac signs, with each tribe having a specific celestial correspondence and spiritual influence.

[3] This refers to the six lower sefirot (divine emanations) in the kabbalistic Tree of Life: Chesed (Kindness), Gevurah (Strength), Tiferet (Beauty), Netzach (Victory), Hod (Splendor), and Yesod (Foundation).

(Crown), suggesting that the most fundamental aspects of human existence are governed by the highest divine emanation rather than by the lower sefirot.

[i] This references Isaiah 65:17 and 66:22, where God promises to create "new heavens and a new earth." The author interprets this metaphorically to mean that Torah study has creative power, allowing humans to participate in ongoing creation through spiritual innovation.

י״ח דף ל״ב ויש ג״כ י״ב מזלות מס״א. ומלמדי לאדם דעת אמרו מלאך מזלו זה שיש לכל אדם ברקיע[ii] כנזכר בעודו חי תמיד מתפלל עליו שישמע הקב״ה תפלתו. וזהו שומע תפלה. אינו אומר שומע תפלות.[i] ומה היא התפלה עדיך כל בשר יבואו. ע״כ אין רשאין למעלה לומר שירות עד שיאמרו ישראל למטה. שכל ענין שאדם עושה מלאך מזלו מתראה באותו ענין למעלה שמכין עצמו למטה. וזהו וגם אני שמעתי את נאקת בני ישראל וגם לרבות מלאכי מזלם. ובשהיו ישראל מתגברים בקול שופר ובחצוצרות היו ברקים יוצאים מן הארון כמו שיוצאים ברקים וקולות למעלה ושוברין שרי השבעה עממין וזהו קול ה׳ שובר ארזים. וסמך לזה ממדרש רבה פ׳ במדבר דף קמ״ד ע״א א״ר אלעזר בן פדת בשם רבי יוסי בן זמרא בשעה שהיו ישראל נוסעים היו ב׳ נצוצים של אש יוצאים מתוך ב׳ בדיו של ארון כדי לפגוע שונאיהם וכו׳. שכן משה אומר כי ה׳ אלהיך הוא עובר לפניך אש אוכלה הוא ישמידם וגו׳. וכתיב אשר כגובה ארזים גבהו ואשמיד פריו ממעל ושרשיו מתחת פריו ממעל זה מלאך מזלם. ואח״כ ושרשיו מתחת.[ii] ואמרו אם

twelve constellations from the Other Side.[4]

Those who teach knowledge to humanity said that this guardian angel that every person has in the firmament,[5] as mentioned, constantly prays for them while they are alive, that the Holy One, blessed be He, should hear their prayer. This is the meaning of "[God] who hears prayer." It does not say "who hears prayers" [in the plural]. And what is the prayer? "To You all flesh shall come." Therefore, they are not permitted above to recite songs until Israel recites them below. For in every matter a person does, their guardian angel appears in that same matter above, preparing itself below. This is the meaning of "And I have also heard the groaning of the children of Israel"—"also" comes to include their guardian angels.

When Israel would intensify the sound of the shofar and trumpets, lightning would emerge from the Ark, just as lightning and sounds emerge above and break the princes of the seven nations. This is the meaning of "The voice of the Lord breaks the cedars." Support for this comes from Midrash Rabbah, Numbers, page 144a: "Rabbi Eleazar ben Pedat said in the name of Rabbi Yose ben Zimra: When Israel would journey, two sparks of fire would emerge from between the two poles of the Ark to strike their enemies, etc." For thus Moses says: "For the Lord your God is He who goes before you as a consuming fire; He will destroy them," etc. And it is written: "Though their height was like the height of cedars, yet I destroyed their fruit from above and their roots from beneath." "Their fruit from above"—this refers to their guardian angel, and afterward, "their roots from beneath."

[1] "The Other Side" (Sitra Achra) is a kabbalistic term for the realm of evil or impurity, suggesting that there are twelve negative constellations that mirror the twelve holy constellations.

[2] The concept of a personal guardian angel (mazal) combines astrological and angelological elements in Jewish mysticism, suggesting that each person has a celestial representative that advocates for them in the divine court.

[i] The concept that each person has a celestial representative or guardian angel (mazal) is found in various rabbinic sources. This represents a personalized connection between the human and divine realms, with the angel serving as both advocate and spiritual counterpart.

[ii] The author makes a grammatical observation about the liturgical phrase "shome'a tefillah" (who hears prayer) being in the singular rather than plural, and interprets this to mean that God first hears the prayer of one's guardian angel before hearing the person's own prayer.

[i] The author interprets the verse from Amos 2:9 about destroying the fruit of the Amorites from above and their roots from beneath as referring first to their celestial guardian angel (mazal) and then to their physical presence on earth, suggesting that divine judgment affects both spiritual and physical realms.

יש עליו מלאך מליץ שמלאך
מזלו של אדם מתפלל עליו
קודם שיתפלל האדם וזהו טרם
65 יקראו ואני אענה למלאך מזלו.
ובהתפלל האדם אח״כ על עצמו
כבר קדמו אחר ברחמים. נקל
לתפלתו להיות נשמעת. וזהו
עוד הם מדברים ואני אשמע.
70 וזהו שמעה ה׳ צד״ק שהוא
כח המזל אח״כ הקשיבה רנתי
האזינה תפלתי. וכן אומר צדק
לפניו יהלך ואח״כ וישם לדרך
פעמיו. וכבר נודע מדברי הזהר
75 פרשת תרומה דף קנ״א שבשעה
שישראל מסדרים בבית הכנסת
סדור שירות ותשבחות והתפלה.
שמתקבצים שלש מחנות מלאכים.
האחד הם המשבחים לקב״ה ביום
80 עם ישראל בשירי דוד. והב׳ הם
הנמצאים בכל קדושה שישראל
מקדשים למטה ושולטים על כל
המתעוררים בכל הרקיעים עבור
התפלות של ישראל. והמחנה
85 השלישי הם בתולות עליונות
שמתקנים עם השכינה ומקשטים
אותה לעלות לפני המלך ה׳
צבאות. ואלה הם מחנות
עליונים על כלם ומתקנים
90 בסוד תפלה מיושב ומעומד
כנדרש למעלה. ובזמירות אנו
מכניסים כל שירי הנבראים
הנכללים בסוד פרק שירה בכח
צורת האדם שהוא רודה על כלם
95 בזה אנו מכלילים כל מיני זמרה.
ובפרט מהנבראים תחתוני׳
בהיכל לבנת הספיר וגם פיוט
יעידון יגידון מורה על זה[i] ובזה
מכלילים ומקדשים כל חלקי
100 העשיה בתקון הקרבנות אחר י״ח
ברכות שקודם התפלה שבברכות
ההם מקדשים כל צרכי בני
אדם להיותם בכח הקדושה וכל

They said: "If there is for him an angel advocate"—for a person's guardian angel prays for them before the person prays, and this is the meaning of "Before they call, I will answer" their guardian 65R
angel. And when the person afterward prays for themselves, another has already preceded them with mercy, making it easier for their prayer to be heard. This is the meaning of "While they are still speaking, I will hear." And this is the meaning of "Hear, 70R
O Lord, righteousness" which is the power of the mazal, and afterward, "Give ear to my cry, listen to my prayer." Similarly, it says, "Righteousness shall go before Him," and afterward, "and shall set us in the way of His steps." 75R

It is already known from the words of the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 151, that when Israel arrange songs of praise and prayer in the synagogue, three camps of angels gather. The first are those who praise the Holy One, blessed be He, during the 80R
day with Israel through the songs of David. The second are those found in every sanctification that Israel sanctify below, and they rule over all those who awaken in all the firmaments for the prayers of Israel. And the third camp are the supernal maid- 85R
ens who adorn themselves with the Shekhinah and decorate her to ascend before the King, the Lord of Hosts. These are camps superior to all of them, and they are established in the mystery of the seated and standing prayer, as explained above. 90R

Through songs of praise, we incorporate all the songs of created beings included in the mystery of Perek Shirah (Chapter of Song) through the power of the human form that rules over all of them. In this way, we include all types of melody, particularly 95R
from the lower created beings in the Palace of the Sapphire Brick.[1] The liturgical poem "Ye'idun Yaggidun" (They testify, they declare) indicates this, and through this we incorporate and sanctify all parts of the World of Action in the establishment 100R
of the sacrifices after the eighteen blessings before the prayer. In those blessings, all the needs of human beings are sanctified to be in the power of

[1] This refers to the first of seven celestial palaces (heikhalot) in the World of Formation (Yetzirah). In kabbalah, it is associated with Exodus 24:10, "under His feet was the likeness of a pavement of sapphire stone."

[i] This refers to a liturgical poem recited during the Kedushah prayer of the Musaf service on Sabbaths and festivals, which describes how all creation testifies to God's glory. The author uses this as an example of how human prayer incorporates the songs of all created beings.

האר בע יסודות תחתונים נכללים
בחומר הראשון והוא נכלל בז׳
ככבי לכת והם באזור המזלות
והוא בגלגל החלק והוא ברקיע
ערבות והוא בשבעים שרים.
ומדור השבעים שרים מהאומות
שלא הכירו בורא עולם יהיה
ברקיע שהוא למעלה מהגלגלים
שאינו מסבב ובחלק שכנגד א״י
בו שרפי קדש ששם השכינה
ושרים החצונים נגד ח״ל ובו
צבא השמים שהם השרים ועל
זה כתיב ונמקו כל צבא השמים
וכל צבאם וגו׳ כי יסבב סיבוב
אחר הרקיע. סנדלפון יש לו
שבעה מדורין[i] כמו שיש שבעה
היכלות ליצירה ושבעה לבריאה
ושבעה ספירות מחסד ולמטה
מספרים כ״ח. וכן ללבנה למטה
כ״ח מחנות תחתונים ובמדרגות
הנקראים אישים שאמרו קצת
שמשם שכל הפועל. והם בעשר
כתות מלאכים הממונים על
התקופות והמזלות והימים
והשעות והחדשים והם מלאכי
קדושה מעופפים במציאות
ונקראים צפור כנף והם אופנים
ותחתיהם ע׳ שרים ואופנים
אלו ממונים על כתות העשייה
ומשם עולים כלם להכלל בהיכל
ראשון שביצירה שהוא לבנת
הספיר.[ii]

holiness.

All four lower elements are included in the primordial matter, which is included in the seven planets, which are in the zodiacal belt, which is in the smooth sphere, which is in the firmament of Aravot,[2] which is among the seventy princes. The dwelling of the seventy princes of the nations who did not recognize the Creator of the world will be in the firmament that is above the non-rotating spheres. In the portion opposite the Land of Israel are holy seraphim, where the Shekhinah dwells, and the external princes are opposite the Diaspora, and in it is the host of heaven, which are the princes. Concerning this, it is written: "And all the host of heaven shall dissolve and all their host shall fall," etc., for it will circle after the firmament.

Sandalphon has seven dwellings,[1] just as there are seven palaces for the World of Formation and seven for the World of Creation, and seven sefirot from Chesed downward, totaling twenty-eight. Similarly, the moon below has twenty-eight lower camps and levels called Ishim (Men/Fires),[2] which some say is the source of the Active Intellect. They are in ten groups of angels appointed over the seasons, constellations, days, hours, and months, and they are holy angels flying in existence, called "winged birds." They are Ophanim (Wheels),[3] and beneath them are seventy princes. These Ophanim are appointed over the groups of the World of Action, and from there they all ascend to be included in the first palace of the World of Formation, which is the Palace of the Sapphire Brick.

[1] Aravot is the seventh and highest heaven in rabbinic cosmology, believed to be where God's throne of glory resides. The term appears in Psalm 68:5, "Extol Him who rides on the clouds [aravot]."

[2] Sandalphon is an archangel in Jewish tradition often associated with prayer, believed to take human prayers and fashion them into crowns for God. The text describes his realm as structured in correspondence with higher spiritual worlds.

[3] Ishim is the lowest of the ten orders of angels in Jewish mysticism, closest to humanity. The term can be understood as meaning either "men" or "fires," reflecting their intermediate nature between human and angelic realms.

[4] Ophanim are a class of angels described in Ezekiel's vision (Ezekiel 1:15-21) as wheel-like beings covered with eyes. In the angelic hierarchy, they are associated with the sphere of Chokmah (Wisdom) and the movement of divine will.

[i] Sandalphon is an archangel in Jewish tradition often associated with prayer, believed to take human prayers and fashion them into crowns for God. The author describes Sandalphon's realm as having seven levels, paralleling the seven lower sefirot and the celestial palaces of higher worlds.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The text refers to this section of the Zohar to explain how three camps of angels gather when Israel prays, showing how human prayers on earth have corresponding celestial responses in higher realms. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah, Numbers — The text cites this midrash

פרק כ״ט

Chapter 29

כל הנדרש נרמז בשירי זמרה ובפרט במזמור הללו את ה׳ מן השמים וגו׳ ושם שירת החיה וכל בהמה וגו׳ מלכי ארץ וגו׳ בחורים וגו׳. ואמרו בראש פרקי שירה[i] כל העוסק בפרק שירה זה בעה״ז זוכה ללמוד ונצול מיצה״ר וכו׳. והפליגו לדבר בשבחו. ואמר ר׳ אלעזר כל האומר שירה זו בעולם הזה זוכה ואומרה לעה״ב ואני מעיד עליו שהוא בן העה״ב ונצול מכל מיני משחית וכו׳. ובפרט האומרים שירה שנמנו שם הם ס״ח[ii] כי מינים הם יהיו כללות הנבראים התחתונים השופכים שיח לפני מלכם ואחריהם כל הפרטים ימשוכו. ועיין בפירוש פרק זה למה פרט אלו ולא זולתם. ואמירת פרק שירה זה לדעתי ירצה להתבונן במהות כל מין ומין עם בחינת שירתו איזה יחוד גורם ומעין אותו היסוד יכלול בנשמתו ויכנים כל פרטי השירות בפסוקי הזמירות בהיכל לבנת הספיר[iii] ומשם

All that is required is alluded to in songs of praise,[1] particularly in the psalm "Praise the Lord from the heavens," where there is the song of the beast, all animals, kings of the earth, young men,[2] and so on. It is stated at the beginning of Perek Shirah (Chapter of Song) that whoever engages with this chapter in this world merits to study and is saved from the evil inclination, etc. They spoke at length in its praise. Rabbi Eleazar said: "Whoever recites this song in this world merits to recite it in the World to Come, and I testify about him that he is destined for the World to Come and is saved from all kinds of destructive forces, etc." In particular, those creatures enumerated there number sixty-eight, for these species represent the totality of the lower created beings who pour out their meditation before their King, and all individual creatures follow after them. See the commentary on this chapter as to why these particular creatures are specified and not others.

The recitation of this Chapter of Song, in my opinion, means to contemplate the essence of each species along with the nature of its song, what type of unification it causes,[3] and to incorporate something of that foundation into one's soul. One should bring all the particular songs into the verses of psalms in

[1] The opening phrase establishes the author's view that liturgical psalms contain mystical significance beyond their plain meaning, particularly regarding cosmic harmony.

[2] This references the structure of Psalm 148, which presents a hierarchical order of creation praising God, from celestial beings to earthly creatures to human society.

[3] In Kabbalistic thought, 'unification' (יחוד) refers to the mystical harmonization of divine attributes or worlds. The author suggests each creature's song creates a specific type of cosmic harmony.

to provide scriptural support for the idea that divine power (symbolized by sparks from the Ark) can overcome enemies, paralleling how the sound of prayer and shofar can break negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The text refers readers to this section for deeper understanding of the mystical concept of mazal, suggesting that this source contains further elaboration on the celestial influences that affect human souls. | Cf. Perek Shirah (Chapter of Song) — The text refers to this ancient mystical work as the source for understanding how all created beings offer praise to God, which humans can incorporate into their prayers, thereby unifying all levels of creation.

[ii] Perek Shirah (Chapter of Song) is a Jewish liturgical text that catalogs the 'songs' (Biblical verses) attributed to various animals, plants, and natural phenomena. Dating possibly to the Talmudic era, it expresses the kabbalistic idea that all creation praises God.

[iii] The text states there are 68 (ס״ח) creatures listed in Perek Shirah. This numerical value is significant in Jewish mysticism.

[i] The 'Palace of the Sapphire Brick' refers to a celestial realm in Kabbalistic cosmology, associated with Exodus 24:10 where the elders of Israel saw under God's feet 'a paved work of sapphire stone.' In Heikhalot literature, it's one of the heavenly palaces through which prayers ascend.

יעלה אותם בסוד צלמו ודמותו
הכולל כל הנבראים עליונים
ותחתונים ויכללם ביחודו בכח
30 תפלתו. וכמו שישראל למטה
צריכים שסנדלפון יקשור כתרים
לקונו[i] בתפלתן של ישראל
ומיכאל מקריב נשמותיהם[ii] וכן
הרבה פרטים מתבארים בפרקי
35 היכלות בהיכלי הקדושה שיש
מחנות רבות ואוכלוסין בלי
מספר שמעלים יחוד התחתונים
לגבהי מרומים ומל׳ הבוחר
בשירי זמרה כוללם כלם בה
40 ומתראה לפני המלך ה׳ צבאות
בכחם. כדרך זה כל ברואי
תבל תלויים בנשמת האדם שהוא
מלך עליהם בתחתונים. ועל
ידו ובכח חלקי נשמתו מעלה
45 כל שירותיהם ותושבחותיהם
לפני השכינה. וזהו שאמר אדם
הראשון לכל הנבראים בואו
נשתחוה ונכרעה נברכה לפני
ה׳ עושנו. כי בלעדו לא היה
50 להם רשות ליראות את פני המלך
ה׳ צבאות והוא היה המריק
להם שפעם. וזהו ורדו בדגת
הים ובעוף השמים וגו׳. וזה
יכוין האדם בזמירות והעושה
55 יחוד זה בעולם הזה גם כן
יזכה לעשות דוגמתו בעולם
הבא שהוא יעלה כל מלאכים
הממונים למטה ויריק עליהם
מברכות שתקבל נשמתו לפנים
60 מהפרגוד וכלם יהיו תלויים
בו והוא בתפלותיו מכליל
ההיכלות זה בזה עד היכל קדש
הקדשים ובזה מעלה המלכות
עד הבינה ובינה מתעלית למקום

the Palace of the Sapphire Brick,[4] and from there elevate them through the mystery of one's image and likeness,[5] which encompasses all created beings, both celestial and terrestrial, and include them in one's 30R
unification through the power of prayer. Just as Israel below requires that Sandalphon bind crowns for his Creator through the prayers of Israel, and Michael offers up their souls, and many other details are explained in the Chapters of the Heavenly 35R
Palaces regarding the sanctuaries of holiness—where there are numerous camps and countless multitudes that elevate the unification of the lower beings to the heights of heaven—so too "the One who chooses songs of praise" includes them all within it and ap- 40R
pears before the King, the Lord of Hosts, through their power.

In this way, all creatures of the world depend on the human soul, which rules over them in the lower realms. Through the human being and through the 45R
power of the portions of his soul, all their songs and praises are elevated before the Divine Presence. This is what Adam, the first man, said to all created beings: "Come, let us prostrate ourselves and bow, let us kneel before the Lord our Maker." For without 50R
him, they would have no permission to appear before the King, the Lord of Hosts, and it was he who channeled divine abundance to them. This is the meaning of "and have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the birds of the sky, etc." 55R

This is what a person should intend through psalms. One who performs this unification in this world will also merit to do its likeness in the World to Come, where he will elevate all the angels appointed below and pour upon them from the blessings that 60R
his soul receives within the divine curtain. They will all depend on him, and through his prayers, he includes the palaces one within another up to the Holy of Holies, thereby elevating Malkhut

[1] This celestial realm represents a specific stage in the ascent of prayers through the spiritual worlds. The metaphor of the 'sapphire brick' suggests both transparency (allowing divine light to shine through) and solidity (providing structure).
[2] This refers to the biblical concept (Genesis 1:26-27) that humans are created in God's image, which in mystical thought gives them unique power to unify and elevate all creation.

[i] According to the Talmud (Chagigah 13b), Sandalphon is an angel who stands behind the Divine Chariot and weaves crowns for God from the prayers of Israel.
[ii] The archangel Michael is traditionally viewed as offering the souls of the righteous as sacrifices upon the heavenly altar, particularly in Jewish apocalyptic literature.

האין העליון[iii] ומשם לנשמות הנשמות יוצר הכל ברוך הוא. ויש שירה למעלה ממלאכי חסד שהם מים העליונים[iv] מנעימי שירה ביום ומלאכי דין מזמרי שירה בלילה והשכינה מתעוררת לשיר על ידם והיינו במעשה ידיך ארנן. וישראל גורמים השירה שלימה. למלאכים כאשר יבא לקמן הנה כמה רב גובריה של אדם ילוד אשה בחסד אל גבר עליו והמשילו על כל מעשה ידיו ועל פיו יחנו ועל פיו יסעו אם משמרת ה׳ ישמור וזה בחייו וכל שכן וקל וחומר במותו יזכה לשמש במרום בראש חולה מכל אשר שת הקב״ה תחת רגליו וסבותיו ועל כן גדול עון המספר בבית הכנסת[i] שהוא מפריד וגורע הנאמנות העליון. וגרסי׳ בפרק חלק אמר ר׳ יהושע בן לוי כל האומר שירה בעולם הזה זוכה ואומרו לעולם הבא. אמר רב ששת כל המלמד תורה בעולם הזה זוכה ומלמדה לעולם הבא שנאמר וכו׳. וכן המנהג הצבור בנחת בעולם הזה. ואמרו בברכות כד הוו מפטרי רבנן מבי רבי ואמרי ליה מבי רבי חנינא הוו אמרין הכי וכו׳ וסיים רגליך ירוצו לשמוע דברי עתיק יומיא. ואולי מלאך מזלו של אדם[ii] הוא ממחנות אלו שמקבלים סיוע מתפלתן של

(Kingdom) to Binah (Understanding),[1] and Binah ascends to the place of the Supernal Nothingness, and from there to the Soul of Souls, the Creator of All, blessed is He. 65R

There is song above from the angels of Kindness, who are the upper waters that make pleasant music by day, and the angels of Judgment who sing at night. The Divine Presence is stirred to sing through them, which is the meaning of "in the works of Your hands I will rejoice." Israel causes the complete song for the angels, as will be explained later. Behold how great is the power of a human being born of woman,[1] as divine kindness prevails over him, and He gave him dominion over all the works of His hands. By his command they encamp, and by his command they journey, if he keeps the charge of the Lord. This is during his lifetime, and all the more so after his death, when he will merit to serve on high, at the head of all that the Holy One, blessed be He, has placed beneath his feet and around him. Therefore, great is the sin of one who engages in mundane conversation in the synagogue, for he separates and diminishes the supernal faithfulness. 70R 75R 80R 85R

We learn in Chapter Chelek that Rabbi Joshua ben Levi said: "Whoever recites song in this world merits to recite it in the World to Come." Rav Sheshet said: "Whoever teaches Torah in this world merits to teach it in the World to Come, as it is said, etc." Similarly, one who leads the congregation calmly in this world [merits to do so in the World to Come]. And they said in Tractate Berakhot: "When the Rabbis would take leave of Rabbi [Judah the Prince]"—and some say, "When they would take leave of Rabbi Hanina"—"they would say thus... 90R 95R

[1] In Kabbalistic cosmology, prayer elevates divine energy from Malkhut (the lowest sefirah representing this world) to Binah (a higher sefirah associated with divine understanding), facilitating cosmic harmony.

[2] This phrase emphasizes both human grandeur (having dominion over creation) and human limitation (being mortal, 'born of woman'), creating tension between humanity's exalted and finite nature.

[i] The 'Supernal Nothingness' (אין העליון) is a kabbalistic term for the highest, most ineffable aspect of divinity, beyond human comprehension and description.

[ii] The 'angels of Kindness' being 'upper waters' refers to the kabbalistic interpretation of Genesis 1:7, where the division of waters symbolizes different spiritual realms and their angelic inhabitants.

[iii] The Talmud (Berakhot 5b) strongly condemns idle talk in synagogues. The author gives this a mystical dimension, suggesting it disrupts the cosmic unification of earthly and heavenly prayer.

[i] The concept of each person having a 'guardian angel' (מלאך מזלו) is found in various rabbinic sources. The author connects this to the three groups of angels that greet the righteous upon death, mentioned in the Talmud (Ketubot 104a).

ישראל ואלו יהיו גם כן הג׳ כתות
100 של מלאכי השרת הבאים לקראת
האדם במותו נגד מה שקדש
עצמו במחשבה בדבור ומעשה
להיות כי נהנו ממנו ומתורתו
ומתפלתו בחייו. ואמרו בפ׳
105 תרומה שכשמזדמנים כל המחנות
עליונות להיות חברים עם
ישראל וישראל למטה אינם
באים לסדר תפלותיהם ולשבח
להקב״ה אינם עולים למעלה
110 ואין בידם לשבח לו כראוי ונתן
טעם לזה בגין דשבחא דקב״ה
אצטריך למהוי כחדא עילא
ותתא עילאין ותתאין בשעתא
חדא וזהו ובאפס לאום מחתת
115 רזון. ובמלין עשרה מזדמנים
להיות חברים עמהם. ואמרו
בתקונים דף י״ד על פסוק שימני
כחותם הכי אמרה שכינתא אע״ג
דאנת מסתלק מעלמא דיוקנך לא
120 אעדי מני לעלם כחותם דאתדבק
ביה רשימו דמריה כחותמא כמו
שישראל משימים עליהם כחותם
עולי של הבורא בתפלה של יד
וראש ובברית מילה ושבת ויום
125 [i] טוב:

[May] your feet run to hear the words of the Ancient
of Days." 100R

Perhaps a person's guardian angel is from these heavenly camps that receive assistance from the prayers of Israel. These would also be the three groups of ministering angels that come to greet a person at death, corresponding to how he sanctified 105R himself in thought, speech, and deed, for they derived pleasure from him, from his Torah, and from his prayer during his lifetime. They said in Parashat Terumah that when all the celestial camps gather to be companions with Israel, but Israel below does 110R not come to arrange their prayers and praise the Holy One, blessed be He, the angels cannot ascend above and are unable to praise Him properly. The reason given for this is "because the praise of the Holy One, blessed be He, needs to be as one, above 115R and below, higher and lower beings at the same time." This is the meaning of "without people, a nation falls." When there are ten [for a minyan], they gather to be companions with them.

And they said in Tikkunim, page 14, regarding 120R the verse "Set me as a seal," that thus said the Shekhinah: "Even though you depart from the world, your image will never depart from me, like a seal whose impression remains with its owner"[1]—like a seal—just as Israel places upon themselves the 125R exalted seal of the Creator in the tefillin of the hand and head, in the covenant of circumcision, on Sabbath, and on festivals.

[1] This beautiful metaphor from Song of Songs is reinterpreted to suggest that even after death, the soul's impression remains with God. The human-divine relationship transcends physical existence.

[i] Cf. Psalm 148 — The author uses this psalm as a foundational text for understanding how all created beings offer praise to God, establishing a cosmic hierarchy of praise that humans can participate in and elevate. | Cf. Perek Shirah — The author cites Perek Shirah as a model text for understanding how all creation praises God, and how humans can elevate these praises through proper intention and ritual practice. | Cf. Psalm 95:6 — This reference establishes humans as mediators who lead all creation in proper worship, emphasizing humanity's central role in the cosmic order. | Cf. Genesis 1:26-28 — The author interprets this dominion not as mere control but as a spiritual responsibility to elevate the praises of all creation. | Cf. Psalm 92:5 — The author connects this to the Divine Presence being stirred to sing, suggesting that divine joy and human joy are interconnected through proper worship. | Cf. Proverbs 14:28 — The author reinterprets this verse mystically to suggest that without human worship on earth, the angelic praise in heaven is incomplete. | Cf. Song of Songs 8:6 — This verse is given a mystical interpretation where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) speaks these words, expressing how the human soul's impression remains with God even after death. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The author cites the Zohar to explain that human prayer on earth is necessary for angelic praise in heaven to be complete, establishing a cosmic dependency between realms. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Tractate Sanhedrin (Chelek) — The author uses this teaching to establish continuity between religious practices in this world and their continuation in the afterlife.

פרק ל׳

Chapter 30

יען כי האדם ונפשו יש לה מזל ברקיע[ii] עוד יש לנו לדעת שכל נפש המהללת השכינה בעוה״ז אף לאחר מיתה המלאך מהלל למעלה באותו הקול עצמו[i] שהצדיק היה רגיל בו כדי שיזכור הקב״ה זכותו לו ולדורו ולזרעו כי המלאך והמזל המגינים על האדם הם כדמותו שנאמר ויראני את יהושע הכהן הגדול. וכן ראיתי פניך כראות פני אלהים[ii] כי ראה דמות עשו כדמות מלאך שלו כן כתב הציוני בפ׳ וירא. ושלוחי הצבור בפרט וכן מי שיש לו קול ערב וכל אדם גם כן יהיה שמור ויקר דבר זה בעיניהם ופיהם תהיה תמיד נחל נובע מקור רנה ותפלה כי לא תהיה להם לעולם הפסק אפי׳ אחר מיתתם. וזהו לדעתי שתקנו מסדרי התפלות ושבחך אלהינו מפינו לא ימוש לעולם ועד וכן ולנצח נצחים קדושתך נקדיש כי אפי׳ אחר המות הצדיק משבח ומהלל לא לבד נשמתו ורוחו למעלה ברם קלוסו עולה גם כן מן העולם התחתון ע״י מלאך מזלו כנזכר על העצמות כתיב כל עצמותי תאמרנה ה׳ מי כמוך. וכן כתיב לא המתים יהללויה

Since man and his soul have a mazal in the firmament,[A] we should also know that every soul that praises the Divine Presence in this world—even after death, the angel continues to praise above with the same exact voice that the righteous person was accustomed to using, so that the Holy One, blessed be He, will remember his merit for him, for his generation, and for his descendants.[1] For the angel and the mazal that protect a person[A] are in his likeness, as it is said, “And he showed me Joshua the High Priest.” Similarly, “I have seen your face as one sees the face of God,” for he saw Esau’s likeness as the likeness of his angel, as the Tziyoni wrote in the section of Vayera. Particularly prayer leaders, as well as anyone with a pleasant voice, and indeed every person, should treasure and value this in their eyes, and their mouths should always be “a flowing stream, a source of song and prayer,” for there will never be an interruption for them, even after their death. This, in my opinion, is why the arrangers of prayers established “And Your praise, our God, shall not depart from our mouths forever and ever,” and likewise, “For all eternity we shall sanctify Your holiness,” because even after death, the righteous person continues to praise and extol—not only through his soul and spirit above, but his glorification also rises from the lower world through his guardian angel, as mentioned. Concerning the bones, it is written, “All my bones shall say: ‘LORD, who is like You?’” And it is also

[A] Or: “have a celestial representative in the heavens” — This alternate translation clarifies the technical kabbalistic concept of ‘mazal’ as a representative entity rather than just a fortune or destiny. This might be more immediately comprehensible to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[B] Or: “and the celestial destiny that protects a person” — This alternate emphasizes the protective aspect of the mazal concept and might be preferred if focusing on the functional rather than ontological aspects of mazal.

[1] The text emphasizes the intergenerational impact of righteousness, suggesting that the merit of a righteous person continues to benefit not just themselves but their entire lineage.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that each person has a celestial counterpart or ‘mazal’ in the heavens that influences their destiny and serves as their spiritual representative in the upper worlds.

[ii] The text presents a mystical understanding that the praise offered by a righteous person during their lifetime continues after death through their celestial representative (guardian angel), preserving their unique ‘voice’ or spiritual signature.

[iii] The text reinterprets Jacob’s statement to Esau in Genesis 33:10 in a mystical way, suggesting Jacob recognized the divine aspect or angelic counterpart of Esau.

ומאן אינון רשעים שבחייהם קרויים מתים שכן ראש החצונים כמוס באוצרות הקדושה[iii] והוא עתיד לקבל מתוק והעד רישיה דעשו הקבור במערת המכפלה לרגלי יעקב[i] והנמשך אחריהם הוא גוף בלא ראש וכן כל יורדי דומה[ii] כי שם בגיהנם אין מעשה וחשבון אבל אנחנו עמו נברך יה בעה״ו ובעה״ב מעתה ועד עולם לעולם נשיר ונזמר ונאמר לפניו הללויה. ובשאדם מתפלל בכוון הלב דמותו של מעלה מנושק בחבה[iii] [iv]

written, "The dead do not praise the LORD"—and who are they? The wicked, who even during their lives are called dead. For the head of the external forces is hidden in the treasuries of holiness,[B] and it is destined to receive sweetening.[C] The evidence is Esau's head, which is buried in the Cave of Machpelah[A] at Jacob's feet. And what follows after them is a body without a head,[1] and so are all who descend to silence,[2] for there in Gehenna there is no work or reckoning. But we, His people, shall bless the LORD in this world and in the World to Come, from now and forever; we shall forever sing, make music, and say before Him: Hallelujah. And when a person prays with focused intention, his heavenly image is kissed with affection[3]

[A] Or: "the root of the negative spiritual forces is concealed within the treasuries of holiness" — This alternate more explicitly clarifies that 'external forces' refers to negative spiritual entities, and that their 'head' refers to their spiritual source or root.

[B] Or: "and it is destined to be transformed and redeemed" — This alternate expresses the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening' (mituk) in more accessible theological terms of transformation and redemption, which might be preferred for readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[C] Or: "Esau's head, which according to tradition is buried in the Cave of Machpelah" — This alternate makes it clearer that this statement refers to a rabbinic tradition rather than a biblical fact, which might be preferred for more scholarly translations.

[1] This metaphor describes the wicked who lack spiritual direction or connection to their divine source—they are like a body without a head, representing action without proper spiritual intention or guidance.

[2] This phrase ('yordei dumah') refers to those who die, particularly those who experience spiritual silence after death due to their wickedness in life.

[1] This metaphorical 'kiss' represents the divine connection established through proper prayer with

[i] This expresses the kabbalistic concept that the 'head' or highest aspect of the external forces (forces of impurity) has its root in holiness and will eventually be rectified or 'sweetened.'

[ii] This refers to a rabbinic tradition that when Esau's head was severed during his burial, it rolled into the Cave of Machpelah and came to rest at Jacob's feet, symbolizing the eventual spiritual rectification of even the negative forces.

[iii] This biblical phrase refers to those who descend to the grave or the realm of silence (Psalms 115:17), which in kabbalistic thought refers to souls that experience spiritual silence in Gehenna.

[iv] This describes the mystical concept that when a person prays with proper intention (kavvanah), their celestial image or spiritual counterpart in the upper worlds receives divine affection, represented as a 'kiss.'

[v] Cf. Zohar — This passage draws heavily on Zoharic concepts about the nature of the soul after death, particularly the idea that the righteous continue to praise God even after death and that their merit continues to benefit their descendants. | Cf. Genesis 32:31 — The reference to "I have seen your face as one sees the face of God" comes from Jacob's words to Esau, which in this passage is interpreted mystically to suggest that Jacob saw Esau's angelic counterpart. | Cf. Zechariah 3:1 — The text quotes "And he showed me Joshua the High Priest" from Zechariah's vision to demonstrate that angels appear in the likeness of the humans they correspond to. | Cf. Psalms 35:10 — The quotation "All my bones shall say: 'LORD, who is like You?'" is used to show that even physical remains have a spiritual connection that continues after death. | Cf. Psalms 115:17 — The text quotes "The dead do not praise the LORD" but reinterprets it to refer specifically to the wicked, who are spiritually dead even while alive, rather than the righteous dead. | Cf. Sefer HaTziyoni — The text explicitly references the kabbalistic work Sefer HaTziyoni regarding the concept that Esau's appearance reflected his angelic counterpart.

ומתוך שנודע זה למלאך שלו
מכניס חבת שמים בלבו וזה סימן
גדול לאדם בתפלתו בעת שנכנס
חשק היחוד ואהבת שמים בלבו
וח״ו בהפך אם יד עליון נוגע
באדם נדחף כמו שנאמר כי יד
ה׳ נגעה בי. וסנדלפון בורר
התפלות כאדם שבורר כסף
וזהב ואבנים טובות ומרגליות
לתקן עטרה[i] והוא יודע לאיזה
צד העטרה יש לקבוע אותה
התפלה אם נגד הפנים כדכתיב
שפכי כמים לבך נכח פני ה׳ או
לאחורי הכבוד על דרך שנאמר
ושועתי לפניו תבא באזניו. ודאי
שכוונת שלוחי צבור בתפלתם
לזכות כל אחד מדיוקני הנשמות
שעומדים בקהל ההוא ועמם כל
כללות שבעים רבוא דיוקנאות
הנכללים בהם כל עם ה׳ כמו
שבהארות הויה אחת מוסיפים
כח וחיל לכל ההויות הקדושות
שכלם משולבות יחד ונתנו
מרועה אחד בנזכר למעלה.
וכן צורת האדם כולל כל ציור
ד׳ פני המרכבה וכל היוצר
מראש ועד סוף בפרטי אבריו
וגידיו ועורקיו ושאר מציאות
שבגופו ונפשו וכוחו ונשמתו.
על כי מנהג החכמים לנענע

And because his angel knows this, it instills love of Heaven in his heart,[4] and this is a great sign for a person during prayer when the desire for divine unification and love of Heaven enters his heart. And Heaven forbid the opposite—if the divine hand touches a person, he is pushed away, as it is said, "For the hand of the LORD has touched me." Sandalphon sifts through the prayers like a person who selects silver, gold, precious stones, and pearls to fashion a crown,[A] and he knows on which side of the crown to set each prayer—whether facing the front, as it is written, "Pour out your heart like water before the face of the LORD," or behind the Glory, as it is said, "And my cry came before Him, into His ears." Certainly, the intention of prayer leaders in their prayers is to bring merit to each of the soul-images standing in that congregation, and with them all the collective seventy thousand soul-images included among them[1]—all the people of the LORD—just as when the illuminations of one Divine Name increase the power and strength of all the holy Divine Names, which are all interwoven together and given by one Shepherd, as mentioned above. Similarly, the human form encompasses all the images of the four faces of the Divine Chariot[B] and everything formed from beginning to end in the details of his limbs, sinews, veins, and other aspects of his body, soul, strength, and spirit. This is why it is the custom of the wise to sway their bodies during Torah study and songs of praise, to fulfill "All my bones shall say..."

[A] Or: "Sandalphon refines the prayers like an artisan who sorts silver, gold, precious stones, and pearls to craft a crown" — The alternate translation emphasizes the artisanal aspect of the process with 'refines' and 'artisan,' which might better convey the meticulous, skilled nature of what Sandalphon does with prayers. The original translation accurately captures the meaning.

[B] Or: "Similarly, the human form encompasses all the patterns of the four faces of the Merkavah" — Using 'Merkavah' instead of 'Divine Chariot' preserves the technical mystical term that would be recognized by readers familiar with Jewish mysticism, though the original translation is perfectly clear.

intention (kavvanah). In kabbalistic thought, the 'kiss' represents a direct spiritual connection between the human soul and divine presence.

[2] The Hebrew term 'חבת שמים' (love of Heaven) refers specifically to a divinely inspired love for the celestial realms, which comes as a result of proper prayer and divine service.

[3] The number 'seventy thousand' (שבעים רבוא) has mystical significance, often representing the totality of Jewish souls. The term 'דיוקנאות' (soul-images) refers to the spiritual impressions or forms of human souls as they exist in higher realms.

[i] This reference to Sandalphon sorting prayers is based on Talmudic and mystical traditions that describe this angel as being responsible for taking human prayers and fashioning them into crowns for God. The metaphor of selecting precious materials highlights the idea that not all prayers are of equal quality or purpose.

עצמם בתורה ובשירי זמרה לקיים כל עצמותי תאמרנה וגו׳:[ii] ובדוגמת אבריהם בכח שלהבת נשמתם מתעוררים בשירם ובזמרם כל כלליות הנבראים ונוצרים ונעשים בכח ההויו״ת קדושות הנכלל רוחניות באותיות ונקודות התורה והתפלה והברכה ואמרו בירושלמי דסוכה פרק החליל בשם הלל הזקן אע״פ שיש לפניו כמה קלוסין חביב הוא קלוסן על ישראל יותר מהכל מ״ט נעים זמירות ישראל יושב תהלות ישראל. וכלל גדול לאדם להשתתף בסוד נפש רוח ונשמה שבו כל ברכה וקדושה ויחוד שגם היא תשתתף עם השרפים והחיות והאופנים ושאר המדרגות לשבח יוצרנו: ועל הכל בשעונה ברוך הוא וברוך שמו אחר כל ברכה ובפרט אחר י״ח ברכות בל חזרת העמידה כי אז הוא גמר היחוד במחברת השנייה ככתוב בספרי המקובלים. נ״ל שטוב לכוין ברוך הוא סוד העצמות או הרצון המתפשט מא״ס בעל הרצון הקדמון נשמה לנשמות תוך הספירות להחיותן.[i] וברוך שמו יכוין ליחד העצמות והרצון עם ספירות הכלים המקבלים הארתו ובכחו מראים פעולותיהם הם כפי הכנת המקבלים למטה

And in the pattern of their limbs, through the flame of their souls, they awaken in their song and their melody all the collective created, formed, and made beings through the power of the holy Divine Names, whose spirituality is included within the letters and 80R
vowel points of the Torah, prayer, and blessing. And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sukkah, chapter "The Flute," in the name of Hillel the Elder: "Even though He has many praises before Him, the praise of Israel is more beloved to Him than all oth- 85R
ers. What is the reason? 'The pleasant songs of Israel, He who dwells amid the praises of Israel.'" It is an important principle for a person to participate, through the mystery of the soul, spirit, and higher soul within him, in every blessing, sanctifica- 90R
tion, and unification, so that it too may join with the seraphim, the holy beasts, the wheels, and the other ranks in praising our Creator. And above all, when one responds "Blessed is He and blessed is His Name" after every blessing, especially after the eigh- 95R
teen blessings in the repetition of the Amidah, for then is the completion of the unification in the second joining,[1] as written in the books of the Kabbalists. It seems to me that it is good to direct one's intention with "Blessed is He" to the mystery of the Essence, or 100R
the Will that extends from the Infinite One, Master of Primordial Will, Soul of souls within the sefirot, giving them life[A]. And with "Blessed is His Name," one should intend to unify the Essence and the Will with the sefirot of the vessels that receive His illu- 105R
mination and through His power manifest their actions according to the preparation of the receivers below. The words "Blessed are You, LORD" in every instance represent the mystery of binding the se-

[A] Or: "to direct one's intention with "Blessed is He" to the mystery of the Divine Essence, or the Will that emanates from Ein Sof, Master of Primordial Will, serving as the Soul of souls within the sefirot, animating them" — This alternate uses 'Ein Sof' (the untranslated technical term) instead of 'the Infinite One' and 'animating' instead of 'giving them life,' which might better convey the technical kabbalistic concept. The original translation is quite accurate, however.

[1] The phrase 'המחברת השנייה' (the second joining) refers to a specific stage in the kabbalistic understanding of prayer, particularly during the repetition of the Amidah, when divine unifications are believed to take place at higher levels than during the silent Amidah.

[i] The Jewish practice of swaying (shuckling) during prayer and Torah study is here given a mystical interpretation. Rather than being merely a cultural custom, it is presented as a deliberate technique to engage one's entire physical being in divine service.

[ii] This passage reflects the Lurianic Kabbalistic concept of divine emanation, where Ein Sof (the Infinite) contracts and extends itself through various stages to animate the sefirot. The term 'soul of souls' suggests the idea that divine Will serves as the animating principle for all spiritual dimensions.

ומלות ברוך אתה ה׳ בכ״מ הוא
סוד קשר הספירות במאצילם
ולכן הכריעה בברוך להמשיך
השפע לספירות להכינם אל
היחוד. ואחר הכנה זו קושרם
ומיחדם למעלה וזהו זוקף בשם
ובכריעה וזקיפה יכוין בא״ס
שעל ידו הוא קשורם ויחודם
ממעלה למטה וממטה למעלה
בין בסוד השפעה בין קשר בין
יחוד. ואח״כ במלת אמן כבר
נודע כי הוא יחוד הוי״ה ואדנו״ת
יחד ששמנה אותיות אלו הם כלל
כל האצילות עליון[i] וכתר כולל
הכל למעלה הנכלל בקוצו של
יו״ד ומלכות כוללת הכל למטה:
ויסוד נקרא שר הפנים שהוא שר
שני פנים שהם הוי״ת אדנו״ת [ii]

firot to their Emanator,[2] and therefore one bows at 110R
"Blessed" to draw down the divine flow to the sefirot to prepare them for unification. After this preparation, one binds them and unifies them above, and this is "straightening at the Name." In bowing and straightening, one should direct intention to the Infi- 115R
nite One, for through Him is their binding and unification from above to below and from below to above, whether in the mystery of emanation, binding, or unification. Afterward, with the word "Amen," it is already known that it represents the unification of 120R
YHVH and ADNY together, for these eight letters comprise all the supernal emanation, with Keter including everything above, contained in the point of the Yod, and Malkhut including everything below. And Yesod is called the Prince of the Face, for it is 125R
the prince of the two faces, which are YHVH and ADNY.[1]

בסוד חשמ״ל שהוא בגימטריא
שד״י אדנ״י[iii] אמצעי בין

In the mystery of Chashmal,[2] which has the numerical value of [the divine names] Shaddai Adonai, serv-

[1]The text describes the mystical significance of bowing during prayer as creating a channel for divine energy to flow into the sefirot (divine emanations), preparing them for unification. This reflects the kabbalistic view that human ritual actions have cosmic effects.

[2]Yesod (Foundation) is described as mediating between the divine names YHVH (representing mercy and masculinity) and ADNY (representing judgment and femininity), functioning as the connecting point between these two aspects of divinity.

[1]Chashmal (חשמ״ל) is a mysterious luminous substance mentioned in Ezekiel's vision (Ezekiel 1:4,27) that became significant in Jewish mystical tradition. In Kabbalah, it represents an intermediary spiritual force that connects different divine realms.

[i]The text assigns profound mystical significance to the common practice of responding 'Amen' in prayer. The numerical value of Amen (אמן) in Hebrew is 91, which equals the combined value of the divine names YHVH (26) and ADNY (65), representing the unification of divine mercy and judgment.

[ii]Cf. Book of Job 19:21 — The author cites Job's lament about divine affliction to illustrate the negative spiritual state of being pushed away from divine presence during prayer. | Cf. Lamentations 2:19 — This reference illustrates one type of prayer that is directed 'toward the face' of God, representing a direct, frontal approach in prayer. | Cf. Psalm 18:7 — This verse is contrasted with the previous reference to demonstrate another type of prayer that approaches God from 'behind the Glory,' suggesting a different modality of divine connection. | Cf. Psalm 35:10 — This reference explains the mystical significance of physical movement during prayer, suggesting that even one's body should participate in divine praise. | Cf. Zohar — This passage draws on Zoharic concepts of how human prayer activates and elevates all created beings across multiple spiritual worlds (Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah). | Cf. Psalm 22:4 — This verse is cited to demonstrate the unique spiritual potency of Israel's prayers compared to angelic praise, suggesting that human prayer has greater power to effect divine unification. | Cf. Ezekiel's Vision of the Divine Chariot (Ezekiel 1) — This references Ezekiel's vision of the merkavah (divine chariot) with its four-faced beings, suggesting that the human form mystically encompasses all these divine aspects. | Cf. Prayer liturgy — This references the standard congregational response during the repetition of the Amidah prayer, assigning profound mystical significance to this liturgical practice.

[i]The author is explaining that the mystical entity Chashmal has the same numerical value (gematria) as the combined divine names Shaddai and Adonai. This establishes a correspondence between this angelic substance and specific divine attributes.

השם הגדול והכינוי. ומלאך
130 מטטרו״ן שהוא בין המלאכים
כלב בגוף[iv] נקרא שר השנים
שהוא שר שני פנים אלו בעולמות
התחתונים: ולהיות כי אין בידינו
כח וחיל מפני מיעוט ידיעתנו
135 ליחד כראוי בתפלתנו ע״כ אולי
תקנו לנו שנמלך באבות העולם
מסדרי התפלות[i] באמרנו ואני
ברוב וגו׳ להזכיר לפניו יתברך
זכותם שיהיה לנו למעוז לעת
140 התפלה ונזכה ליחד ולתקן מעין
מה שהיו מתקנים הם בכח תפלתם
והקב״ה הנותן שכר על המחשבה
טובה כמעשה הוא יגמור על
ידינו כפי כוונתנו שהוא ליחד
145 ולעורר הרצון העליון מעין
מה שעשו אבותינו הקדושים
וגם הם יפתחו לנו שערי תפלה
ויכניסוה לפנים מהפרגוד ובזה
נפש ברכה תדושן ירצה הרצון
150 והתאוה שיש לאדם לברך וליחד
תשבע בדשן עליון ואלהינו
מרחם המרווה מרצונו לחוסים
בו גם הוא יורה כפי רצון
ותאות המתפלל והמיחד: וכפי
155 כוונת הצדיק במעשיו ובשבחיו
בעודו בעולם הזה כדוגמא

ing as an intermediary between the Great Name and 130R
the Appellation.[3] And the angel Metatron, who is
among the angels like the heart in the body,[A][ii] is
called the Prince of the Two Faces,[I] as he is the
prince over these two aspects in the lower worlds.

Since we lack the power and strength, due to 135R
our limited knowledge, to properly unify [the divine
realms] in our prayers,[A] perhaps they instituted for
us to consult with the Patriarchs, the arrangers of
prayers,[2] when we say "But I, in the abundance of
Your kindness..." [Psalms 5:8]—to invoke their merit 140R
before the Blessed One, that it might be a stronghold
for us in the time of prayer. Thus we may merit to
unify and rectify in a manner similar to what they
would accomplish through their prayers. And the
Holy One, blessed be He, who rewards good inten- 145R
tion as if it were action, will complete through us
according to our intention, which is to unify and
awaken the Supernal Will in a manner resembling
what our holy ancestors did. They too will open for
us the gates of prayer and bring it within the divine 150R
curtain [Pargod].[3] Through this, "the soul of bless-
ing will be satisfied"—meaning that the desire and
longing that a person has to bless and unify will be
satiated with supernal abundance. And our merciful
God, who satisfies those who take refuge in Him with 155R
His will, will also direct [the divine flow] according
to the desire and longing of the one who prays and

[A] Or: "who is among the angels as the heart is in the body" — This slight rewording better conveys the simile that positions Metatron's function in the angelic hierarchy as analogous to the heart's central role in the body's functioning.

[B] Or: "And because we do not possess the power and strength, due to our deficient knowledge, to perform proper unifications in our prayers" — This alternate translation is more literal and retains the technical language of 'performing unifications' (ליחד), which refers specifically to the kabbalistic practice of unifying divine names and attributes through prayer.

[2] The 'Great Name' refers to the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), while 'the Appellation' refers to the divine name Adonai (Lord) used to replace the pronunciation of YHVH in prayer.

[3] In Kabbalistic tradition, Metatron is considered to have two aspects or 'faces'—one facing upward toward the divine realm and one facing downward toward the created worlds, allowing him to serve as the perfect intermediary.

[4] This refers to the Jewish tradition that the three daily prayer services were instituted by the biblical Patriarchs: Abraham (morning), Isaac (afternoon), and Jacob (evening).

[5] The Pargod is a mystical concept representing the divine veil or curtain that separates the divine presence from the lower spiritual realms. Only the most worthy prayers can penetrate this barrier.

[ii] Metatron is compared to the heart in the body—just as the heart circulates blood throughout the body, Metatron circulates divine influence throughout the angelic realms. This metaphor appears in several kabbalistic texts to explain Metatron's central role in mediating divine energy.

[iii] The author suggests that the rabbis who arranged the prayer liturgy instituted references to the Patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) so that their merit would assist our prayers in ascending to the divine realms, compensating for our own spiritual limitations.

ההיא תהיה שבח מלאך מזלו
המהלל אחר מותו. וכמו ששלוחי
צבור בוונתן לתקון קהלם עם
כל לעדת ישראל ומהבל פיהם
יתהוה מציאות חדש כמו מלאך
כלול מכל בחינות הנשמות
הקהל ההוא[ii] ע״ד ההוא יהיה
התעוררות המלאך אחר מותם.
עוד חשבתי כי טוב לשליח צבור
בקוראו בני הקהל לספר תורה
יכוין להדביק נפשותם ברוחניות
התורה עץ החיים שבתוך גן
עליון וזה בכוונת יעמוד בבוד
ר׳ פלוני בי הנשמה נקראת
כבוד כדכתיב למען יזמרך
כבוד[i] ויכוין כי נשמתו תאיר
ותתדבק למעלה בעץ החיים
כמו שגופו נאחד למטה לקרא
בתורה. ואוחז בעמוד התורה
כי עץ חיים היא למחזיקים בה
ולזה תהיה כוונת שניהם ואולי
זה יהיה מנהג האומרים לעולה
בכבוד. ובנשיקת התורה יכוין
להדביק רוחו ברוחניותה וזה
מלבד שאר כוונות רמות אשר
באו בספרי המקובלים לעולה

unifies.

According to the intention of the righteous person in his deeds and praises while in this world, so will be the praise of his guardian angel who glorifies [God] after his death. Just as the prayer leaders direct their intention toward rectifying their congregation along with the entire community of Israel, and from the breath of their mouths a new entity is formed, like an angel[A] comprising all the soul aspects of that congregation, in this manner will be the arousal of the angel after their death.

Furthermore, I thought it would be good for the prayer leader, when calling members of the congregation to the Torah,[1] to intend to attach their souls to the spirituality of the Torah, the Tree of Life within the supernal garden. This is the intention of "Let the honor of Rabbi So-and-so arise," for the soul is called "honor,"[2] as it is written: "That glory may sing praise to You" [Psalms 30:13]. He should intend that his soul will shine and cleave above to the Tree of Life, just as his body is united below to read from the Torah, grasping the pillar of the Torah, for "it is a tree of life to those who hold fast to it" [Proverbs 3:18]. This should be the intention of both [the prayer leader and the one called up], and perhaps this is the custom of those who say to the

[A] Or: "and from the breath of their mouths a new existence is created, like an angel" — The term 'מציאות' (metziyut) in kabbalistic contexts often refers to a complete existence or being rather than just an entity, suggesting the profound creative power attributed to prayer in forming new spiritual realities.

[1] The author is providing a mystical interpretation of the ritual of calling people up for Torah readings (aliyot), suggesting that this physical act has profound spiritual significance in connecting souls to divine wisdom.

[2] The identification of the soul with 'kavod' (honor/glory) is significant in Kabbalah, as it connects the human soul with the divine attribute of Kavod (Glory), suggesting the soul's divine origin and nature.

[i] This presents a remarkable kabbalistic concept that the collective prayer of a congregation creates a new angelic entity composed of the spiritual aspects of all participants. This spiritual creation persists even after the individuals who formed it have died.

[ii] The author explains that when someone is called to the Torah with the phrase 'let the honor (kavod) of so-and-so arise,' this has a deeper meaning because 'kavod' (honor) is also a term for the soul, as supported by the verse from Psalms 30:13.

[i] Cf. Pirkei Heichalot — The passage draws on Heichalot literature's concept of heavenly gates and the Pargod (divine curtain) that separates the divine presence from lower realms, through which prayers must pass | Cf. Zohar III:132a — The text draws on Zoharic concepts regarding how the breath of prayer creates spiritual entities and how human intentions below influence divine unifications above | Cf. Ezekiel 1:27 — The text references Chashmal from Ezekiel's vision, which in kabbalah became understood as an intermediary spiritual substance connecting divine realms | Cf. Tikunei Zohar 19 — The passage draws on Tikunei Zohar's depiction of Metatron as mediating between spiritual realms, serving as the 'heart' connecting the upper and lower divine body

[ii] לקרות בתורה:

one who ascends [to the Torah reading] "with honor." When kissing the Torah, one should intend to attach his spirit to its spirituality, and this is in addition to other lofty intentions that appear in the books of the kabbalists for one who ascends to read the Torah. 185R

פרק ל״א

Chapter 31

ידוע כי יש י״ב שרפים ממונים על כל אחד מבתי כנסיות[i] וגם הם יהיו סיוע לכל היחודים הנעשים בהם והשמים יענו את הארץ. ואגב אפרש טעם הנלע״ד על מאי דאמור רבנן שטוב שבכל בית הכנסת יהיו בו י״ב חלונות: ובזה נתן טעם לחלוק סדרי התפלות הנמצאים בתוכנו ספרדים לועזים אשכנזים ליוואנטיני קטאלאני צרפתים והרבה בזה. והנה אין לנו אלא אלוה אחד וכלנו ליה עינינו. אך טעם השתנות זה יהיה שכל אחד מי״ב שבטי ישראל יש לו חלון אחד ברקיע כפי בחינת נשמת שבטו מצד מחנה מיכאל או גבריאל וכו׳ שד׳ מחנות אלו מתחלקים לי״ב. ג׳ בכל סטר בנודע.[ii] וגם שכל נשמות ישראל הם ממוצא אחד דכתיב כל הנשמה תהלל יה ולא כתיב כל הנשמות.[iii] מ״מ נצוצות הקדושה בירידתם למטה ממלכות משם יפרדו לי״ב. וכל שרף מעלה תפלת בני שבטו דרך חלון ומדרגה הקדושה המתווך

It is known that there are twelve seraphim appointed over each synagogue, and they also assist with all the unifications performed in them, and "the heavens shall answer the earth."[1] Incidentally, I will explain what seems to me to be the reason for what our Rabbis said, that it is good for every synagogue to have twelve windows: This also provides a reason for the division of prayer orders found among us—Sephardim, those speaking foreign languages, Ashkenazim, Levantines, Catalans, French, and many others like these. Indeed, we have but one God, and all our eyes look to Him. However, the reason for these variations is that each of the twelve tribes of Israel has one window in the firmament according to the soul-quality of its tribe from the side of the camp of Michael or Gabriel, etc., as these four camps divide into twelve, three in each direction, as is known. And although all the souls of Israel come from one source, as it is written "Let every soul (singular) praise the Lord"[2] and not "all souls" (plural), nevertheless, the sparks of holiness, in their descent below from Malkhut, separate into twelve divisions. Each seraph raises the prayers of members of its tribe through the window and holy level that serves as intermediary for its soul. For this reason, it is appropriate that there be twelve windows in the synagogue.[3] Twelve seraphim are 5R 10R 15R 20R 25R

[1] This is a biblical phrase from Hosea 2:23, recontextualized here to describe the mystical correspondence between heavenly and earthly prayer.

[2] From Psalm 150:6. The author draws a mystical insight from the grammatical form, noting that the Hebrew uses the singular 'neshamah' rather than plural 'neshamot', suggesting the essential unity of all Jewish souls.

[1] The recommendation for twelve windows in a synagogue derives from Talmudic sources (Berakhot

[ii] The concept of twelve seraphim presiding over synagogues connects physical places of worship with celestial architecture, reflecting the kabbalistic principle that earthly structures mirror heavenly ones.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic arrangement of the twelve tribes in four groups of three, corresponding to the four directions and the four camps of angels mentioned in Numbers 2.

[i] The author uses a grammatical observation about Psalm 150:6 using the singular "soul" rather than plural "souls" to support the mystical concept that all Jewish souls derive from a single source before differentiating.

לנשמתו. ועם זה הטעם נכון
שבבית הכנסת יהיו י״ב חלונות.
ממונים בכל בית הכנסת י״ב
שרפים נגד שבטי יה ולי״ב צנורי
שם ההוי״ה. ויש בכל ב״ה סוד
פני אדם הנשמות הקהל היושבים
לצד מזרח ופני אריה בסוד
היושבים לצד דרום. וכן פני
שור בסוד היושבים לצד צפון.
ופני נשר בסוד היושבים לצד
מערב. ומתחלק כל צד לשלש
בחינות נגד י״ב שרפים נגד
י״ב גבולי אלכסון ושליח צבור
השושבין ביניהם ירמוז לכללות
כלם יחד נגד בחינת הי״ג מקור
לכלם על כן אין לשנות מטבע
תפלתו שלמדוהו אבותיו כי אלו
ואלו דברי אלהים חיים[i] וכל
המשנה ידו על התחתונה.
ואמרי׳ בירושלמי שלח להו
רבי ייסא אע״פ ששלחנו לכם
סדר המועדות פי׳ בתפלות אל
תשנו מנהג אבותיכם נוחי נפש.
ואין ללמוד מקצת בני דורות
אחרונים ששינו סדר תפלתם
מלועז לספרד או איפכא[ii] דמבר
נש זעיר לא ילפין כדאמרי׳
בירושלמי מה את סבור ילפין
עובדא מינך ואפי׳ קביעות
מקום מיוחד בבית הכנסת
צריך לתפלה וזה כדי שיבואו
המלאכים והנשמות באותו ועד
כמנהגם וברבים יהיו עמו כל
שכן שאין להתפלל בב״ה אלא
סדר התפלה הנהגה שם כי כל
הבל קדוש מאחז פני כסא במקום
הראוי ומכוון לו ועם שונים

appointed in each synagogue, corresponding to the tribes of the Lord and to the twelve channels of the Divine Name. In every synagogue exists the mystery of the "face of man"—the souls of the congregation sitting toward the east, and the "face of the lion"—those sitting toward the south. Similarly, the "face of the ox"—those sitting toward the north, and the "face of the eagle"—those sitting toward the west. Each side divides into three aspects, corresponding to the twelve seraphim, the twelve diagonal boundaries, and the prayer leader, the attendant among them, symbolizes the unity of them all together, corresponding to the thirteenth aspect, the source of them all. Therefore, one should not change the pattern of prayer that one's ancestors taught, for "these and these are the words of the living God," and whoever changes, the disadvantage is his.[1] As we say in the Jerusalem Talmud, Rabbi Yisa sent to them: "Even though we sent you the order of festivals," meaning regarding prayers, "do not change the custom of your ancestors of blessed memory." One should not learn from some members of recent generations who changed their prayer order from foreign to Sephardic or vice versa, for one should not learn from an insignificant person, as they say in the Jerusalem Talmud: "Do you think they will learn conduct from you?" Even a fixed special place in the synagogue is necessary for prayer, so that the angels and souls will come to that assembly according to their custom, and "with a multitude they shall be with him." All the more so, one should not pray in a synagogue except according to the prayer order practiced there, for every holy breath grasps the face of the Throne in its proper and designated place, and "with those who change, do not mix." Even regarding one's father's occupation, our Rabbis said that a son

31a), but the author provides a mystical explanation connecting these architectural features to cosmic channels.

[2]This is a play on the Talmudic expression 'kol ha-meshaneh yado al ha-tachtonah' (whoever changes, the lower hand is his), meaning they are at a disadvantage in legal disputes. Here it suggests spiritual disadvantage from changing prayer customs.

[ii]This phrase, originally from the Talmud regarding disagreements between the schools of Hillel and Shammai, is repurposed here to validate diverse prayer traditions as all having divine legitimacy, provided they maintain ancestral continuity.

[iii]This refers to historical shifts in prayer customs, particularly after the Spanish Expulsion (1492) when some communities changed their liturgical traditions. The author views such changes negatively, seeing them as breaking cosmic correspondences.

אל תתערב.[iii] ואפי׳ מאומנות
אביו אמרו רבנן שאל ישנה בנו
כל שכן סדר תפלתו בי אולי
סדר התפלה שלמד בקטנותו
מפי אבותיו ומוריו היא מוקבלת
לנצוץ נשמתו מד׳ מחנות הנזכר
דאינון תריסר משריין קדישין
דאכניש משה ליחדא רתיכא
עילאה קדישא דכתיב ויקהל
משה את כל עדת בני ישראל
לאעלאה מטרוניתא לאתחברא
באבהן ובפרשה תרומה בפרק
שלישי מספרא דצניעותא סדר
הכוונה לכל תפלה ובקשה ואמר
כי השאלות ששואלים מהקב״ה
הם בא׳ מתשעה אופנים יעויין
שם. וכתוב בתקון י׳ כי שלש
חיילות מקב״ה באות בתוך
עם ישראל בכח זמירות שירות
ותושבחות. ובתקון י״ב מוכיח
דשערי דמעה לא ננעלו[i] מפ׳
ותפתח ותראהו והנה נער בוכה
במאי אפתח ליה בדמעה וזהו
בבכי יבואו בזכות בכיה יתאספו
מהגלות: ואמר כי יש היכל
למעלה גנוז שאינו נפתח אלא
בנגון וליה ביון אלישע בשלש
נגונין שנגן. והנשמה נהנית
מהנגון לפי שהיא רגילה בנגונין
בשיר של מ״ה ושיר הגלגלים
ובהיותה בגוף ושמעת נגון נהנית
כמו שהיתה רגילה בהיותה
דבוקה ביסודה ומרוב הערבות
ראויה לשרות עליה רוח אלהים
כפי הנהגתה ויסודה הראשון
ולכן דוד דלית ליה מגרמיה

should not change from it; how much more so regarding the order of prayer, for perhaps the prayer order one learned in childhood from one's ancestors and teachers is suited to the spark of one's soul from the four aforementioned camps, which are the twelve holy encampments that Moses gathered to unify the holy supernal chariot, as it is written: "And Moses assembled all the congregation of the children of Israel"—to bring the Matronita (Divine Presence) to unite with the Patriarchs. In Parashat Terumah, in the third chapter of Safra D'Tzniuta, the order of intention for every prayer and request is explained, saying that the requests we ask of the Holy One, blessed be He, are in one of nine ways—see there. And it is written in the tenth Tikkun that three hosts from the Holy One, blessed be He, come among the people of Israel through the power of songs, hymns, and praises. The twelfth Tikkun proves that the gates of tears are not locked, from the verse: "And she opened it and saw him, and behold, the boy was crying"—with what did she open it? With tears.[1] This is the meaning of "with weeping they shall come"—by virtue of crying they will be gathered from exile.

He also said that there is a palace above that is hidden and opens only through melody, and this is what Elisha intended with the three melodies that were played. The soul derives pleasure from melody because it is accustomed to melodies in the song of MA"H[2] (the Divine Name) and the song of the celestial spheres. When in a body and hearing melody, it derives pleasure as it was accustomed when it was attached to its source. Due to the great sweetness, it is fitting for the spirit of God to rest upon it according to its conduct and original foundation. Therefore, David, who had nothing of his own,[3] needed to

[1] This is a kabbalistic interpretation of Exodus 2:6, where Pharaoh's daughter opens Moses' basket. The Hebrew verb 'va-tiftach' (she opened) is connected to the concept of opening heavenly gates through tears.

[2] MA"H (מ״ה) refers to the divine name YHVH spelled out in a specific way that equals the numerical value 45. The song of MA"H describes celestial harmonies associated with this divine name.

[1] This refers to a kabbalistic concept that David represented the sefirah of Malkhut, which has no

[i] This is a creative interpretation of Proverbs 24:21, which literally means "Do not associate with those who change," typically understood as warning against rebels. Here it's applied to liturgical consistency.

[ii] This references the Talmudic teaching (Bava Metzia 59a) that while the gates of prayer may sometimes be closed, the gates of tears are never locked. The author cites Tikkunei Zohar as proving this from the biblical story of Moses' rescue.

הוצרך לעורר עצמו במיני נגון להמשיך חיים למדתו. ויש היכל אור שנפתח באור התורה. ויש היכל הנבואה שאינו נפתח אלא לחכם גבור ועשיר.[ii] ויש היכל היראה שאינו נפתח רק למי שיש לו יראה. ויש היכל שאינו נפתח אלא לעניים בעטוף בציצית ותפילין. ויש היכל צדיקים שאינו נפתח אלא להם וזהו שער צדיק חי עלמין. והנגון כשעולה עולה בו׳ מדרגות. וכן כשיורד יורד בו׳. ועליו נאמר שוקיו עמודי שש. ועשרה נימין הם סוד העשר אצבעות הבוטשים בנגון. וכן חמשה בכנור של חמש או שש. עוד בנגון נרמז שבעה ושבעה מוצקות וזהו ודוד מנגן ביד. וש״צ המנגן בתפלתו מעלה השבינה לפני המלך העליון מקושטת בשבע רעותיה[i] המובאות לה על ידי התחתונים. ובעלותה כמה מלאכים וכמה מחנות וכמה נשמות עולים עמה שהם נימין דילה.[ii] וכמה מלאכים ונשמות מאירים לפניה הנקראים עיני ה׳. וכמה מצות עולים לפניה וכמה מלאכים עולים עמה הנקראים אזני ה׳ הממונים על קבלת התפלות. עוד עמה עולים אותם הנקראים פני ה׳ מאירים בכמה גוונים ורוחין ואישים הממונים על ריח ועשן הקרבן והם בעלי החוטם. וכן עולין מארי דקלין ודבור הפה. ומארי

arouse himself with various melodies to draw life to his attribute. There is a palace of light that opens with the light of Torah. There is a palace of prophecy that opens only to the wise, strong, and wealthy. There is a palace of fear that opens only to one who possesses fear. There is a palace that opens only to the poor who wrap themselves in tzitzit and tefillin. And there is a palace of the righteous that opens only to them, and this is "the gate of the righteous, the living of worlds." When melody ascends, it rises through six levels, and when it descends, it descends through six levels. Of this it is said, "His legs are pillars of marble."[1] The ten strings represent the mystery of the ten fingers that strike in melody, as well as the five on a harp of five or six strings. Additionally, melody alludes to "seven and seven spouts,"[2] and this is "and David played with his hand." The prayer leader who chants in his prayer elevates the Divine Presence before the supernal King, adorned with her seven companions brought to her by those below. As she ascends, many angels, many hosts, and many souls ascend with her, which are her strings. Many angels and souls shine before her, called "the eyes of the Lord." Many commandments ascend before her, and many angels ascend with her, called "the ears of the Lord," appointed over receiving prayers. Furthermore, those called "the face of the Lord" ascend with her, shining with many colors. Spirits and fiery beings appointed over the scent and smoke of the sacrifice, who are the masters of the nose, also ascend. Similarly, the masters of voices and speech of the mouth ascend, as do the masters of the neck called "ishim" (fiery beings), the masters of hands, the masters of the body, the masters of the covenant, and the masters of the legs—all ascend with her. When she is in her palace, all the prophets ascend there,

light of its own but receives from the higher sefirot, just as the moon receives light from the sun.
[2]This is a quote from Song of Songs 5:15, which in kabbalistic interpretation refers to the divine attribute of Netzach and Hod (Victory and Splendor), the divine 'legs' that support the cosmic structure.
[3]This refers to Zechariah 4:2, describing the Temple menorah with seven lamps and seven spouts to each lamp. In kabbalistic interpretation, these represent the seven lower sefirot and their channels.

[i]These three qualities—wisdom, strength, and wealth—are traditionally associated with those worthy of prophecy, based on Jeremiah 9:22-23.
[ii]This refers to the seven handmaidens or attributes that accompany the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), often associated with the seven lower sefirot or the seven days of creation.
[iii]The metaphor of souls and angels as "strings" of the Divine Presence draws from the image of musical instruments, where each string produces a distinct sound but together create harmony.

דצואר הנקראים אישים. ומאר׳ דידין ומאר׳ דגופא. ומאר׳ דברית. ומאר׳ דרגלין כולם עולים עמה. וכשהיא בהיכלה כל הנביאים עולים שם ודופקים ואומרים אדני שפתי תפתח. עיין מזה בתקון י״ח מדף כ״ח עד דף ל״ז כי יערב ויבוסם לכל קורא בצדק ואשרי המכוין בתפלתו לתקון כזה: [i]

knock, and say, "O Lord, open my lips."[3] Examine this in the eighteenth Tikkun, from page 28 to page 37, for it will be pleasant and sweet to all who call in righteousness, and fortunate is one who directs his intention in prayer toward such rectification. 140R

והבל העולה מהמתפלל מעלה ה״א העליונה לגבי יו״ד ועולה על ידי הקול שהוא וא״ו הבל היורד היא ה״א תתאה שעושה הדבור קריבות מכל ההבלים ומיחד אור ישר בחוזר וחוזר בישר עד אין תכלית. וקי״ל ודבו״ר יחד [ii] וכשאדם מוציא הבלים ודבורים בתפלתו כמה עופין פתחין גדפייהו לקבלא לון. הדא הוא דכתיב כי עוף השמים יוליך את הקול [iii] ומהם

The breath rising from one who prays elevates the upper Hei toward the Yod,[1] and ascends through the voice, which is the Vav. The descending breath is the lower Hei, which creates closeness from all the breaths and unifies direct light with reflected light,[2] and reflected with direct, without end. And we have received the tradition that voice and speech are united, and when a person emits breaths and words in prayer, many birds spread their wings to receive them. This is as it is written: "For the bird of the heavens shall carry the voice," and from these the Holy One, blessed be He, creates worlds. 145R 150R

[1] This phrase from Psalm 51:17 is incorporated into daily Jewish prayer as the opening line of the Amidah prayer. Here it's reimagined as the words spoken by prophetic souls seeking access to the divine palace.

[2] This describes kabbalistic letter mysticism where the four letters of God's name (YHVH) represent cosmic forces. Prayer reunites these forces, particularly joining the 'feminine' Hei with the 'masculine' Yod.

[3] A key kabbalistic concept describing how divine energy flows downward (direct light) and then returns upward (reflected light), creating a circuit of spiritual energy.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The passage draws heavily from Zoharic concepts about prayer, angels, and the Divine Presence. The imagery of the divine chariot with its four faces and the structure of heavenly realms all derive from the Zohar's mystical cosmology. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author explicitly cites several sections from Tikkunei Zohar to substantiate his claims about the divine hosts that come among Israel during prayer and about the gates of tears not being locked. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — The author cites the Jerusalem Talmud to support his argument about not changing ancestral prayer customs, showing how rabbinic authority backs mystical practice. | Cf. Safra D'Tzniuta — The reference to Safra D'Tzniuta in Parashat Terumah points to an esoteric text within the Zoharic corpus that discusses the order of intention for prayers, indicating advanced kabbalistic practice. | Cf. Biblical Four Living Creatures — The four faces (man, lion, ox, eagle) correspond to Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot and are mapped onto the synagogue layout, transforming ordinary space into a cosmic template. | Cf. Story of Elisha and the musician — The reference to Elisha and the three melodies alludes to the biblical story where Elisha called for a musician to help him prophesy, supporting the author's claim about music opening heavenly gates. | Cf. Psalm 24:7 — The description of prophets knocking and saying "O Lord, open my lips" echoes Psalm 24:7 "Lift up your heads, O gates" and Psalm 51:15 "O Lord, open my lips," combining these prayer motifs to describe celestial worship.

[i] The abbreviation וקי״ל stands for 'וקיימא לן' (and we have received the tradition), a rabbinical phrase indicating an accepted teaching.

[ii] This is a quote from Ecclesiastes 10:20, reinterpreted mystically to describe how prayers are carried through spiritual realms.

בורא הקב״ה עולמות. ואמרו
בתקון כ׳[iv] שבינה עולה אל
המלך בעשרה זכרונות ובעשרה
מלכיות ובעשרה שופרות שהם
ג׳ פעמים עשר ועשרה כתות
דמלאכין יתערון לגבייהו
וסלקין לגבי עשר ספירות
ונגונים סלקין מינייהו מרובעים
מסטרא דרביע בד׳ חיות וחיות
קטנות עם גדולות הם שמנה שם
הוי״ה ואדנו״ת יחד. ואמר
כי הנגון בד׳ פנים ולמה תקן
דוד בנור עם שמנה נימין. ויש
נגון העולה בו׳ ויש נגון העולה
בב׳. ויש בחמש כגון ה׳. ויש
בשש דהוא אבגי״תץ.[i] והוא
או״ו. ויש שעולה בג׳ תש״ת
תקיעה לחסד שברים עולה
בנגון הקול לתרועה. תרועה
עולה לעמוד האמצעי. ביחוד
המלך עם המלכה יתעוררו
כל מיני נגון. הה״ד[ii] הללוהו
בתקע שופר הללוהו בנבל
וכנור. ושופר הוא שבינתא:
ולכן מנהגן של ישראל לנגן
בפה בבתי כנסיותיהם בשבתות
וימים טובים זמני היחוד[iii] אך
צריך התעוררות יותר חזק בי״ט
לעורר האושפיזין שהם מקראי

They said in the twentieth Tikkun that Binah ascends to the King through ten Remembrances, ten Kingships, and ten Shofar blasts,[3] which are three times ten, and ten classes of angels are aroused toward them and ascend to the ten Sefirot. Melodies rise from them in four-fold patterns from the aspect of the four Chayot, and small Chayot with large ones correspond to the eight letters of the Divine Names YHVH and ADNY combined.[1] 155R 160R

It is said that melody has four aspects, and this is why David established the harp with eight strings. There is melody that ascends through six, and melody that ascends through two. There is melody through five, corresponding to the letter Hei, and through six, which is ABGITATZ, corresponding to Vav.[2] There is also melody that ascends through three: TASHAT—the Tekiah corresponds to Chesed,[3] Shevarim ascends in the melody of the voice to Teruah, and Teruah ascends to the central pillar. In the unification of the King with the Queen, all types of melody are awakened. This is what is meant by "Praise Him with the blast of the shofar, praise Him with lute and harp." And the shofar represents the Shekhinah. 165R 170R 175R

Therefore, it is the custom of Israel to sing vocally in their synagogues on Sabbaths and festivals, times of unification. However, stronger arousal is needed on festivals to awaken the heavenly guests,[4] who are the "holy convocations" of the supernal holiness of 180R

[1] References the three special sections of the Rosh Hashanah Musaf prayer, each containing ten biblical verses that invoke divine remembrance, sovereignty, and the shofar respectively.

[2] These two divine names (the Tetragrammaton and Adonai) together contain eight Hebrew letters, corresponding to the eight strings of David's harp and representing the complete circuit of divine energy.

[3] ABGITATZ is the first of seven groups of six letters each that form the 42-letter divine name. Here it's connected to the letter Vav (value 6), emphasizing its relationship to the six days of creation and the six directions of space.

[4] The text establishes correspondences between shofar sounds and divine attributes: the long, unbroken tekiah blast connects to Chesed (Loving-kindness), representing wholeness and divine benevolence.

[1] In Kabbalistic tradition, during festivals, spiritual 'guests' (the ushpizin) visit from higher realms. These include biblical figures and divine energies that require active invitation through song and celebration.

[iii] Refers to the twentieth section of Tikkunei Zohar, a foundational kabbalistic text consisting of seventy interpretations of the first word of the Torah.

[iv] The first word of the 42-letter divine name, a mystical sequence used in advanced kabbalistic practices and prayer intentions.

[v] Abbreviation for 'הדא הוא דכתיב' (this is what is written), a common rabbinic phrase introducing a scriptural proof text.

[i] In Kabbalah, Sabbaths and festivals are considered special times when divine masculine and feminine aspects unite, creating heightened spiritual potential.

קדש העליון שהוא קדושת השבת ולקדשם. אבל השבת הקב״ה מקדש ישראל בנזכר ולכן נאמר שמחה במועדים אך קדושת השבת מסתפק מעצמו: ומכוון הנגון בפה בכל יום טוב ובפרט ביום שבועות שהיחוד מתמיד כל היום ובשמיני חג העצרת שהוא גמר היחוד מהמועדים שעברו מיום ר״ה עד אז כנדרש אצלנו. מזה נראה כמה כח הנגון להשלמת יחוד העליון ונתבאר בתקונים במזמור הללו אל בקדשו כל כלי זמר הנזכרים בו על סדר עשר ספירות וכל הנשמה הם חכמה ובינה שבהם תהיה הגאולה לוא״ו וה״א שבשם ואמרו עוד בתקון כ״ב כי ציור נשמותיהם של ישראל חקוקה בכסא. ובעת שהיא מתעוררת למטה בתפלה הכסא מתעורר למעלה וציור הרוח חקוק במלאכים וכשהוא מתעורר למטה בתפלה המלאכים מתעוררים למעלה. והנפש היא חקוקה בד׳ פינות העולם ובזמן שתתעורר בתפלה או מצוה ד׳ פינות העולם מתעוררים עמה. עיין בסוף תקון מ״ה סוד עליית וירידת התפלה לצדיק לבינוני ולרשע והקול סליק והדבור נחית ומלאכי אלהים סלקין ונחתין ביה. עוד בר״מ פרשה כי תצא דף רמ״ג. כי בקול רנה ובקול תפלה ובקול שופר מתקשר יצר הרע תחת יצר טוב. באדרת האזינו אמרו מאן דבעי דירכין מלכא אודניה לגביה יסלסל ברישיה דמלכא היינו תקון ומיתוק הדינים הנרמזים בשערות ויפנה שערי מעל אודנוהי וישמע ליה מלכא בכל מה דבעי. ובספר

the Sabbath, and to sanctify them. But on the Sabbath, the Holy One, blessed be He, sanctifies Israel as mentioned, and therefore "rejoicing" is specified for festivals, while the sanctity of the Sabbath is self-sufficient. 185R

The melody with the mouth is particularly directed on each festival, especially on Shavuot when the unification continues throughout the day, and on Shemini Atzeret, which is the completion of the unification from the festivals that passed from Rosh Hashanah until then, as we have explained. From this, we see how powerful melody is for completing the supernal unification. This is explained in the Tikkunim regarding the psalm "Praise God in His sanctuary," where all the musical instruments mentioned correspond to the order of the ten Sefirot.[1] "All souls" refers to Chokhmah and Binah, through which will come redemption to the Vav and Hei of the Divine Name. 190R 195R 200R

They said further in the twenty-second Tikkun that the image of the souls of Israel is engraved on the Throne.[2] When it is aroused below in prayer, the Throne is aroused above. The image of the Ruach (spirit) is engraved in the angels, and when it is aroused below in prayer, the angels are aroused above. The Nefesh (vital soul) is engraved in the four corners of the world, and when it is aroused in prayer or through a commandment, the four corners of the world are aroused with it. 205R 210R

See at the end of the forty-fifth Tikkun the secret of the ascent and descent of prayer for the righteous, the intermediate, and the wicked—how the voice ascends and the speech descends, and "the angels of God ascend and descend through it." Also, in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Ki Tetze, page 243, it states that through the voice of joy, the voice of prayer, and the voice of the shofar,[3] the evil inclination is bound beneath the good inclination. 215R 220R

In the Idra of Ha'azinu, they said: "One who wishes the King to incline His ear to him should arrange the King's head"—meaning to rectify and sweeten the judgments symbolized by the hairs, and

[2] Psalm 150 lists multiple instruments which kabbalists interpret as corresponding to the ten divine emanations (sefirot), suggesting that different types of music activate different spiritual channels.

[3] Reflects the mystical concept that human souls have their root in the divine realm, specifically in God's Throne of Glory, creating an intrinsic connection that is activated during prayer.

[1] These three types of sacred sound create a spiritual technology that helps transform negative forces (the evil inclination) into positive ones, demonstrating how ritual sound can effect cosmic change.

clear the gates above His ears, so the King will hear him in all that he requests. 225R

In Sefer Hasidim, proof is brought in section 728 that every person has a mazal in the firmament, even though "Israel as a collective is not subject to mazal," individually they are. And while one's guardian angel is with him, no harmful entity can approach. Perhaps this refers to the defending angel, and from it emerges the voice announcing when a person's time has come for elevation, decline, death (God forbid), or escape. If even the slender grasses each have an angel from above that sings and thereby helps that grass grow, how much more so for humans, who encompass higher and lower realms. 230R 235R

They said in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 129, that there is an appointed one over the images of the righteous called "Yehodiom." We have elaborated on this subject because it is pleasant, beneficial, and good for encouraging a person. What pertains to our purpose will be explained in the next chapter, with God's help. 240R 245R

החסידים מביא ראיה בסימן תתשכ"ח שלכל אדם יש מזל ברקיע הגם שאין מזל לישראל בכלל אבל בפרט יש.[i] ובעוד מלאך מזלו אצלו אין מזיק יכול להתקרב אליו. ואולי יצדק בו שהוא המלאך מליץ וממנו יוצא הקול שמודיע הגיע זמנו של פלוני[i] לגדולה או לירידה או למות ח"ו או להמלט. ואם אפי' העשבים דקים יש לכל אחד מהם מלאך מלמעלה המשורר ובזה מגדל העשב ההוא כל שכן לאדם הכולל עליונים ותחתונים. ואמרו בזהר פרשת תרומה דף קכ"ט שממונה יש על הדיוקנאות של צדיקים הנקרא יהודיעם והארכנו בדרוש הזה להיותו ערב ומועיל וטוב לזרז האדם ומה שנוגע לכוונתנו הוא המתבאר לפנינו בפרק הבא בע"ה:[ii]

פרק ל"ב

Chapter 32

כשמגיע זמן האדם למות הוא יודע ומכיר המתים הבאים לקראתו ואם זוכה משיג גם כן בניצוץ השכינה ובכבודה

When a person's time to die approaches, he knows and recognizes the deceased who come to greet him,[1] and if he is meritorious, he may also perceive a spark of the Divine Presence and its glory.[A] For

[A] Or: "and if he merits, he also attains [perception of] a spark of the Divine Presence and

[1] This reflects the Jewish mystical belief that departed souls come to welcome and guide newly deceased souls into the afterlife.

[i] References the Talmudic concept that while the Jewish people collectively transcend astrological influence, individuals may still be affected by celestial forces.

[ii] Refers to the kabbalistic belief that celestial announcements herald major life transitions, including death, based on Talmudic statements that deaths of the righteous are proclaimed in heaven.

[iii] Cf. Ecclesiastes 10:20 — This verse is cited to demonstrate how prayers ascend through spiritual realms via angelic intermediaries, comparing them to birds that carry human utterances heavenward. | Cf. Ezekiel's vision of the Chariot — References the four celestial beings from Ezekiel's throne vision (Ezekiel 1), which in Kabbalah represent fundamental cosmic forces through which divine energy flows into creation. | Cf. Psalm 150 — This psalm is interpreted kabbalistically as describing how different musical instruments and sounds correspond to different sefirot and spiritual channels through which divine unification is achieved. | Cf. Genesis 28:12 — Alludes to Jacob's ladder vision, reinterpreted here to describe how prayer creates a bidirectional channel between human and divine realms, with angels serving as intermediaries carrying prayers up and divine influence down. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author cites specific sections of Tikkunei Zohar, a major kabbalistic text that provides systematic interpretations of Torah through the lens of the sefirot and divine names. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Shabbat 156a — References the Talmudic teaching 'ein mazal l'Yisrael' (Israel has no mazal/astrological destiny) while noting that individually, each person does have a spiritual destiny or guardian force.

כי אז בהתבטל כח גופניי אין
הראיה והשמיעה באמצעות
הכלים בעין ואזן אלא בעין
הנפש לבד[iii] והיא הראיה
והשמיעה האמיתית והנכונה
וזהו תוסף רוחם יגועון.[i] ומלאך
מזלו כאשר בארנו למעלה הוא
רואה מלאך המות כאלו מלא
עינים.[ii] וזה גרם לנו אכילת עץ
הדעת טוב ורע דכתיב ביה וכי
תאוה הוא לעינים פי׳ לראות
מ״ה שהוא מלא עינים:[iii] ואולי
בחינת היותו מלא עינים יורה
כי שט בארץ ומתהלך בה כמו
שאמר הוא עצמו משוט בארץ.
ירצה אז בקטרוגו כנהוג לו
שבני אדם בכל מקום נותנים לו
כח בעונותיהם כי מלאה הארץ
חמס ושוד. ובכל מקום יש לו
שליטה מחמת רבוי העבירות.
ועל כן הוא מלא עינים כי יש לו
צפייה בכל אדם כי אין צדיק
בארץ שלא יחטא. הנה כי בדמות
פרצופו ג״כ מקטרג לפני הקב״ה
[iv]

at that moment, as physical strength wanes,[B] sight and hearing no longer function through bodily organs like the eye and ear, but rather through the eye of the soul alone, which is the true and proper sight and hearing.[1] This is the meaning of "You take away their breath, they expire" (Psalms 104:29). And his guardian angel, as we explained above, sees the Angel of Death as though it were full of eyes. This resulted from our eating of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, about which it is written, "and that it was a delight to the eyes" (Genesis 3:6)—meaning to see that which is full of eyes.

its glory" — The term 'משיג' has connotations of intellectual or spiritual attainment rather than merely perception, suggesting a more active achievement of mystical insight.

[B] Or: "for then, as bodily power is nullified" — This more literal translation captures the stronger sense of complete nullification (התבטל) of physical faculties rather than merely their weakening.

[2] The author presents spiritual perception as superior to physical perception, a common theme in mystical texts across traditions.

[i] This passage contains an important kabbalistic concept that as the physical body weakens at death, the soul's perceptive faculties become more acute, enabling perception of spiritual realities normally hidden during life.

[ii] This is a quote from Psalm 104:29, 'You take away their breath, they expire.'

[iii] The concept of the Angel of Death being 'full of eyes' appears in rabbinic literature, particularly in the Talmud (Avodah Zarah 20b), suggesting its omniscience regarding human actions and mortality.

[iv] The Hebrew 'מ״ה' (MA"H) has a numerical value of 45 and often refers to a divine name in Kabbalah. Here it appears to connect the primordial sin with humanity's desire to perceive divine realities beyond their capacity.

[i] Cf. Talmud, Avodah Zarah 20b — The author draws on this talmudic description to explain the spiritual perceptions of the dying, connecting the Angel of Death's appearance to the primordial sin of eating from the Tree of Knowledge. | Cf. Zohar — The author is working within the Zoharic framework of understanding death as a transition where spiritual perception increases as physical faculties diminish. | Cf. Genesis 3:6 — The author makes an innovative connection between humanity's primordial desire for forbidden sight/knowledge and the dying person's ability to perceive spiritual realities, suggesting that death partially reverses the limitations imposed after Eden.

וכשאדם וחוה עמדו על הרעה שגרמו ידעו כי ערומים הם מלבושי ימיהם שהיו כתנות אור[v] כבתוב בספרא דר״מ[i] בסוד תפלין דמארי עלמא[ii] והיו בו להכנה להוליד נשמות כלן קדושות. ובכתנות עור נתערב טמא בטהור. וכל פגם שיש בו תפיסת ידי אדם קשה לתקן מה שאין כן בשאין בו. וראיה מההרים והאשרות הנעבדות והם ירדו למטה בעונם להתלבש בחצונים ובעלי תאוה המביאים תואנה לעולם אלא שהקב״ה בחסדו עשה להם כתנות עור בסוד תפלין של עור כנדרש אצלנו במקומו. ולנו לדעת כי מעולם לא עלה על דעת אבינו הראשון ועל דעת אשתו חוה שניהם יציר כפיו של הקב״ה אשר נשמתם חצובה בגבהי מרומים כדאיתא בפרשת בראשית ובפ׳ בשלח דף נ״ה ע״א וכן בהרבה מקומות. ולא מלא לבם לעבור על רצון בוראם בעשה ולא תעשה שנצטוו על האכילה ההיא אלא הוסיפו על הצווי וסברו לתקן ולקדש ש״ש בכח אכילתם הקדושה

And when Adam and Eve realized the evil they had caused, they knew they were naked, stripped of their original garments,[2] which had been "garments of light,"[A] as written in the book of Rabbi Moses in the mystery of "the tefillin of the Master of the Universe." These garments had prepared them to produce souls that were entirely holy. But in the "garments of skin,"[A] impurity became mixed with purity. Any defect involving human intervention is difficult to repair,[1] unlike those without human involvement. Evidence of this can be seen in the mountains and sacred trees that were worshipped, which descended below through their sin to clothe themselves in external forces[B] and in those with desire who bring pretexts to the world. However, the Holy One, blessed be He, in His kindness made for them garments of skin according to the mystery of tefillin made of leather, as we have explained elsewhere.

We should understand that it never occurred to our first father or to his wife Eve—both formed by the hands of the Holy One, blessed be He, whose souls were hewn from the heights of heaven, as stated in the portion of Genesis and in the portion of Beshalach page 55a, as well as in many other places—to deliberately violate their Creator's will, the positive and negative commandments they received regarding that eating. Rather, they added to the commandment,[2] thinking to rectify and sanctify God's name

[A] Or: "luminous garments" — The term 'luminous garments' might better convey the mystical radiance implied by the original Hebrew phrase, suggesting spiritual rather than physical garments.

[B] Or: "garments of hide" — 'Garments of hide' emphasizes the material, physical nature that replaced the spiritual garments, highlighting the contrast more explicitly.

[C] Or: "to become clothed in the kelipot (husks of impurity)" — Using the technical kabbalistic term 'kelipot' might better convey the mystical concept being referenced, though it would require the reader to be familiar with kabbalistic terminology.

[1] The original text plays on the double meaning of 'knowing they were naked' (Genesis 3:7), interpreting it as awareness of spiritual rather than merely physical nakedness.

[2] This statement establishes an important kabbalistic principle that human action creates deeper spiritual damage than would occur naturally, making rectification (tikkun) more difficult.

[1] This offers a sympathetic interpretation of Adam and Eve's sin as excessive zeal rather than disobedience, aligning with a rabbinic principle that adding to divine commandments can be problematic (as in the case of Eve adding 'nor touch it' to God's prohibition).

[ii] The Hebrew phrase כתנות אור (garments of light) differs by just one letter from כתנות עור (garments of skin) that appears later in the text. This wordplay is significant in kabbalistic interpretations of Adam and Eve's fall, suggesting their transformation from spiritual to physical beings.

[iii] This likely refers to an esoteric text attributed to Rabbi Moses (possibly Moses de León, traditionally considered the redactor of the Zohar, or Moses Cordovero, another important kabbalist).

[iv] The 'tefillin of the Master of the Universe' is a mystical concept referring to divine emanations. In Kabbalah, human ritual items often correspond to cosmic structures.

שכן נצטוו אכל תאכל לתקון
וסלסול נטיעות הגן בלעיסה
רוחנית להעלות הנאכל למדרגה
העליונה בכח ל״ב שנים נגד ל״ב
נתיבות חכמה העליונה[iii] ששם
היו מוצק ותקון לבריאת כל
הנבראים שכלם בחכמה נעשו
בכח כ״ב אותיות והעשרה
מאמרות שנכלל רוחניות
האותיות בעשר מאמרות שהם
במלכות האדריכל לכל. וכתב
הגאון מורי מפאנו זצ״ל[i] במאמר
חקור דין שלו כי אכל תאכל
היה מ״ע וכל האכילה האמורה
בפסוק הזה בתורה ובמ״ט
הכתוב מדבר. שאלו זכינו
היתה האכילה ההוא נחשבת לנו
כאכילת קדשים וכהנחת תפלין
כמו שהיה מצות פרו ורבו לעין
כל קודם החטא. ואמר כי כן דוד
שהוא חי בגן עדן מקיים עכשיו
המצוה הזאת בכל עת ובאכילה
הזאת הנחש הסביר להם פנים
והיו סבורים לקדש ש״ש ג״כ
למטה במקום הנהגת הטוב והרע
יחד. ודימו להגביר צד הטוב
ולבלע צד הרע שבעין ההוא
אלא שנהפכו עליהם ציריהם
וסברו לתקן וקלקלו שגבר הרע
ונחלש הטוב כי כן צפה מגיד
מראשית אחרית[ii] בצווייו ואמר
כי ביום אכלך ממנו מות תמות
שגם שכוונתך תהיה להמליך ש״ש

through their holy eating. For they had been commanded "you may surely eat" in order to rectify and elevate the plantings of the garden through spiritual chewing,[3] raising what was eaten to a higher level through the power of thirty-two teeth, corresponding to the thirty-two paths of supernal wisdom, where all created beings were established and repaired, for all were made with wisdom through the power of the twenty-two letters and the ten utterances, the spirituality of the letters being included in the ten utterances, which are in Malchut, the architect of all. 50R 55R

My teacher, the sage of Fano of blessed memory, wrote in his discourse "Investigating Judgment" that "you may surely eat" was a positive commandment, and all eating mentioned in this verse in the Torah refers to mitzvot. Had we been worthy, that eating would have been considered for us like consuming sacred offerings and like putting on tefillin, just as the commandment to be fruitful and multiply was clearly visible before the sin. He said that David, who lives in the Garden of Eden,[1] now fulfills this commandment at all times. In this eating, the serpent presented a favorable appearance to them, and they thought to sanctify God's name also below, in the place where good and evil are governed together. They imagined they would strengthen the side of good and swallow up the side of evil[2] in that tree, but their circumstances were reversed. They thought to repair, but instead caused damage,[A] as evil prevailed and good was weakened. For thus the One who declares the end from the beginning foresaw in His commandments and said, "for on the day 60R 65R 70R 75R

[A] Or: "intended to rectify but instead corrupted" — The terms 'rectify' and 'corrupted' more precisely convey the kabbalistic concept of tikkun (repair/rectification) and its opposite, which is implied in the original Hebrew.

[2] The concept of 'spiritual chewing' suggests that eating in Eden was meant to be a contemplative, mystical act through which physical matter would be elevated to higher spiritual realms.
[3] This refers to the mystical tradition that King David, unlike other deceased figures, continues to live in a special section of the Garden of Eden rather than dying in the conventional sense.
[4] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening the judgments' (המתקת הדינים), the idea that harsh divine forces can be transformed into benevolence through proper spiritual action.

[i] This creates a correspondence between the 32 human teeth and the 32 paths of wisdom described in the Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), an early kabbalistic text.
[ii] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an Italian kabbalist and student of Rabbi Moses Cordovero. The author's reference to him as 'my teacher' suggests a direct intellectual lineage.
[i] This phrase, meaning 'He who declares the end from the beginning,' is drawn from Isaiah 46:10, referring to God's omniscience.

שם ולהגביר צד הטוב והחיים [iii]

you eat of it, you shall surely die," even though your intention will be to enthrone God's name there and to strengthen the side of good and life. 80R

ושיתוקן גם הנהגה זו על ידך
לעת עתה מעשיך לא יהיו רצויים
כי תגביר הדין למעלה והמיתה
למטה וזהו מות תמות.[i] וטעם
מצוה זו היא בטעם האיסור
והמותר שיש לנו שכל ל״ת
שבתורה הוא מפני היות שליטת
סמאל עליו והנהנה ממנו המיתה
הטבעית והרוחנית קופצת עליו
כי סוד האיסור שיש לנו הוא
מה שמתפשטים ענפיו בעולם
הגשמי הזה וכן האיסור לאדם
היה מטעם שליטת ס״מ בענפי
הדעת טוב והיינו רע המתפשט
ועושה פירות ופרי ההוא גורם
המיתה אל הגוף והנפש וחלק
הרע שבעץ הזה אינו לא תאנה
ולא רימון ולא אתרוג ולא חטה
אלא עץ ידוע הנעשה לבוש
וקליפה לשני העצים פנימיים
עץ החיים ועץ הדעת טוב.
כי שלש בחינות הם כנדרש
אצלנו במקום כבודו בשפה

And even though you intended to repair this mode of governance through your actions, at present your deeds will not be pleasing, for they will strengthen judgment above and death below—this is the meaning of "you shall surely die." The reason for this commandment is like the reason for all prohibitions and permissions that we have:[A] every negative commandment in the Torah exists because Samael has dominion over it, and one who derives benefit from it invites natural and spiritual death, for the secret of prohibition that we have is what extends its branches in this physical world. Similarly, the prohibition for Adam was because of Samael's dominion over the branches of the Tree of Knowledge of Good, meaning the evil that spreads and produces fruit—and that fruit causes death to both body and soul. The evil portion of this tree is neither a fig, nor a pomegranate, nor a citron, nor wheat, but rather a known tree that became a garment and shell for the two inner trees:[1] the Tree of Life and the Tree of Knowledge of Good. For there are three aspects, as we have explained in its proper place in clear language, but the Sages compared the order of allusion 85R 90R 95R 100R 105R

[B]Or: "The rationale for this commandment follows the same principle as our understanding of prohibitions and permissions" — This alternate translation captures the comparative nature of the original phrase but uses more natural English phrasing by employing 'rationale' and 'principle' rather than the more literal 'reason' and 'like the reason'.

[1]The concept of 'shells' (קליפות/kelipot) is a fundamental kabbalistic idea referring to the outer layers that conceal divine light. Here, the author is explaining how the forbidden tree functioned as an external covering for deeper spiritual realities.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Bereshit (Genesis) — The text draws on the Zoharic tradition that Adam and Eve initially possessed spiritual 'garments of light' (בתנות אור) that were transformed into physical 'garments of skin' (בתנות עור) after their sin, representing their descent from a purely spiritual to a physical existence. | Cf. Zohar, Beshalach — The author uses this reference to establish the lofty spiritual origins of Adam and Eve, emphasizing that their souls were 'hewn from the heights of heaven,' which makes their sin not one of rebellion but of misguided spiritual aspiration. | Cf. Thirty-two Paths of Wisdom — The author creates a mystical correspondence between the thirty-two human teeth and the thirty-two paths of wisdom in Kabbalistic cosmology, suggesting that Adam and Eve's eating was intended as a spiritual act to elevate creation through this correspondence. | Cf. Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano — The author cites his teacher's interpretation that transforms the conventional understanding of eating in Eden from mere permission to a positive commandment with spiritual significance, comparable to ritual acts like eating sacred offerings or wearing tefillin.

[iii]This references Genesis 2:17 where God warns Adam that eating from the forbidden tree will result in death. The Hebrew phrase "מות תמות" (mot tamut) employs a doubling construction that emphasizes the certainty of death.

ברורה אלא חכמים המשילו
סדר הרמז בספירות ובכחות
רוחניים בתאנים וכו׳. ובן אמרו
120 בתקונים דף ס״ח ע״א סחטה
ענבים ברשו אחרא ועבד יין
נסך ואתעביד אילנא דטוב ורע.
הנה כי מתחלה לא נקרא עדיין
שם רע על אותו האילן ירצה
125 ההנהגה ההיא עד אחר החטא
על דרך שכתבנו למעלה ביצר
הרע. שהיצר הרע היה תבלין
באדם ומעטרא ליה כסאסאה
לשבולתא וידיעה בחצונים
130 הגם שהיא תאוה לעינים אינה
אלא תאוה כלביות[i] כי פנימה
הוא כהפך כדכתיב כי נופת
תטופנה שפתי זרה וגו׳ ומ״ד
תאנה ליקט אותה קודם זמנה
135 כי רצה לעשות התקון ממטה
למעלה והוא לא כן צוה רק כי
יאכל תחלה מעץ הגן ואח״כ
יזכה להמתיק גם עץ הדעת טוב
ורע. ובזה היה מוכן לאכול
140 מעץ החיים כי ג׳ מיני פירות
היו בגן. א׳ פרי הגן. הב׳ עץ
הדעת טוב. הג׳ עץ החיים נגד
ג׳ הנהגות בי״ע. ואמרו בב״ר
פט״ו ומה היתה אותה תאנה ר׳
145 אבין אמר ברת שבע דאמטי ז׳
יומי אבלא לעלמא[ii] ר׳ יהושע
דסכנין בשם ר׳ אלעזר אמר

in the sefirot and spiritual powers to figs, etc. And so they said in Tikkunim, page 68a, "She squeezed grapes in the domain of the Other Side and made libation wine, and it became the Tree of Good and Evil." For initially, the name "evil" was not yet called upon that tree—meaning that governance—until after the sin, as we wrote above regarding the evil inclination. For the evil inclination was a spice in man and crowned him like chaff to grain,[A] and knowledge of external forces, even though it is "a delight to the eyes," is nothing but a dog-like desire, for inwardly it is the opposite, as it is written: "For the lips of a strange woman drip honey,[B] etc." And the one who says it was a fig argues that Adam picked it before its time, for he wanted to accomplish the rectification from below to above, but this is not what was commanded—only that he should first eat from the trees of the garden, and afterward he would merit to sweeten even the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. In this way, he would have been prepared to eat from the Tree of Life, for there were three kinds of fruits in the garden: First, the fruit of the garden; second, the Tree of Knowledge of Good; and third, the Tree of Life—corresponding to the three modes of governance in Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah.[1] And they said in Bereishit Rabbah, chapter 15: "What was that fig? Rabbi Avin said: It was a seven-daughter fig that brought seven days of mourning to the world. Rabbi Joshua of Sakhnin said in the name of Rabbi Eleazar: It was a fig of tail/curse that brought a curse to the world." They

110R 115R 120R 125R 130R 135R

[A] Or: "For the evil inclination was originally meant to be a beneficial seasoning for humanity, adorning the person like the beard of grain adorns the stalk" — This expanded translation more fully conveys the agricultural metaphor where 'סאסאה' refers specifically to the bristly parts of grain. The alternate clarifies that the evil inclination was intended to have a positive function before the sin.

[B] Or: "for beneath its surface lies the opposite reality, as Scripture warns: "Though the lips of the forbidden woman drip honey" — This translation better conveys the sense of deceptive appearances versus hidden reality that is central to the author's point about forbidden knowledge, while making the biblical allusion clearer as a cautionary example.

[1] Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah represent three of the four spiritual worlds in Kabbalah (the highest being Atzilut). Each world represents a different level of divine manifestation, from the most abstract (Beriah/Creation) to the most concrete (Asiyah/Action).

[i] The term "כלביות" (kalbiyut/dog-like) is a strong metaphor comparing forbidden desires to the unrestrained nature of dogs, suggesting base animalistic impulses rather than elevated human consciousness.

[i] This Aramaic phrase means "a seven-daughter [fig] that brought seven days of mourning to the world," creating a wordplay between the seven days of mourning and the consequences of Adam's sin.

ברת אליתא דאמטיאת אליתא
לעלמא.[iii] ולא פליגי רק מר
150 ביאר פגם עונו בעולם היצירה
בז׳ היכלות שבו. ומר פירשו בז׳
מדורין דעשייה כי גבר הפגם
בכלן. פוק עיין ותבין.[i] וב׳
מיתות אלו לדעתי ירמוז עוד
155 הפגם שעשה ביצירה ובעשיה
ב׳ הנהגות התחתונות שלא היה
לו לירד שם אז. ובן אמרו
בתקון י״ט דף מ״א דאדם תניינא
דחב במחשבה ואדם תליתא חב
160 במעשה[ii] דתלת אדם אינון אדם
דבריאה דיצירה דעשיה דלאו
כל חובין שוין. ובתקון נ״ט
ביאר טעם משטמת הנחש לאדם
ובתיקון ס׳ פירש איך היה המות
165 בעץ הדעת טוב ורע והרבה מיני
עץ יש יעויין שם. ומתקון נ״ט
עד תקון ס״ט מדבר בעון אדם
ובפרט בדף קי״ג ע״א רשב״י
הודיע שם פגם עון זה לר״א בנו
170 דמטא לאתר עילאה דכל עלאין
ועל כן לא יראני האדם וחי ושם
ביאר הספירות והצחצחות ואור
קדמון. ולמעלה ממנו עילת
העילות. ובתקון ע׳ ביאר נעשה
175 אדם על אדם קדמון. ושם פי׳
כמה דרכים על פסוק נעשה
אדם וכלם כאחד טובים וישרים
למוצאי דעת ושם הודיענו עוד
כי יש שבעה היכלות שבניינם הם
180 בשבע שמות מאבגי״תץ. ובתקון
כ״א מהנוספים פי׳ ז׳ שמות
מם״ב עם ז׳ ספירות ועם שבעה
קולות: ואגב אמר בתקון ע׳
כי שכינה עליונה אינה יורדת
185 על הצדיקים אלא בשבת ויום

do not disagree; rather, one explained the blemish of his sin in the world of Yetzirah with its seven palaces, and one explained it in the seven chambers of Asiyah, for the blemish prevailed in all of them.[2] Go, examine, and understand. And these two deaths, in my opinion, further allude to the blemish he caused in Yetzirah and Asiyah, the two lower modes of governance, where he should not have descended at that time. And so they said in Tikkun 19, page 41, that the second Adam sinned in thought and the third Adam sinned in deed, for there are three Adams: the Adam of Beriah, of Yetzirah, and of Asiyah, for not all sins are equal. And in Tikkun 59, he explained the reason for the serpent's hatred toward man, and in Tikkun 60, he explained how death was in the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, and there are many kinds of trees—examine there. And from Tikkun 59 to Tikkun 69, it discusses Adam's sin, particularly on page 113a, where Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai revealed there the blemish of this sin to his son Rabbi Eleazar, that it reached the highest place of all high places, and therefore "no man shall see Me and live." And there he explained the sefirot, the radiances, and the primordial light, and above it, the Cause of all causes. And in Tikkun 70, he explained "Let Us make man" in relation to Primordial Adam. And there he interpreted several approaches to the verse "Let Us make man," and they are all good and right together for those who find knowledge. And there he further informed us that there are seven palaces whose construction consists of the seven names from ABGITATZ. And in Tikkun 21 of the additional Tikkunim, he explained the seven names of the 42-letter Name with the seven sefirot and with the seven voices. And incidentally, he said in Tikkun 70 that the supernal Shekhinah descends upon the righteous only on Sabbath and festivals, but masters of repentance draw it down upon themselves

140R 145R 150R 155R 160R 165R 170R

[1] The author is harmonizing seemingly contradictory rabbinic opinions by suggesting that Adam's sin created spiritual damage across multiple levels of reality simultaneously.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase contains a wordplay where "אליתא" (alita) can mean both "tail" and "curse," suggesting that the fig brought a curse upon the world.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase meaning "Go, examine, and understand" is a common rabbinic expression encouraging deeper contemplation beyond the surface meaning of the text.

[iv] This Aramaic phrase describes three levels of Adam who sinned in different ways: "the second Adam sinned in thought and the third Adam sinned in deed." This reflects the kabbalistic concept of Adam manifesting in different spiritual worlds.

טוב ברם בעלי תשובה מורידים
אותה עליהם בכל יום ושעה
ורגע. וכבר כתבנו למעלה טעם
לזה. ומתבאר שם חלוק שבין
190 אדם דאצילות לאדם דבריאה
יצירה ועשיה ואמר כי במשה
היה מרכבה שלמה לבדו כמו
שהיה בג׳ אבות. ואדם עילאה
הוה במשה. וזהו וירא ראשית
195 לו. וזהו מה שהיה הוא שיהיה
ואשר להיות כבר היה זה אדם
הראשון ונצוצות נשמת משה
מתפשטות בכל דור ודור בבעלי
תורה להאירם בה: [i]

every day,[1] hour, and moment. And we have already written above the reason for this. And it is explained there the difference between the Adam of Atzilut and the Adam of Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah, and he said that in Moses there was a complete chariot by himself,[2] just as there was in the three Patriarchs. And the supernal Adam was in Moses. This is the meaning of "he saw the first for himself," and this is the meaning of "What has been is what will be, and what has been done is what will be done"—this refers to the first Adam, and sparks of Moses' soul extend into every generation[1] among the masters of Torah to illuminate them with it. 175R 180R 185R

פרק ל״ג

Chapter 33

נחזור לדרושנו כי מדברי
המדרשים מתברר שראוי היה
אבינו הראשון לזכות גם לתקן
ולהעלות בכחו גם ההנהגה
5 התחתונה הלזו אלא שאכלה
פגה.[ii] ובכח האכילה ההיא
היה מוכן לילך מחיל אל חיל
ולהגיע בגוף ונפש אל העדן
אשר אין שם אכילה ושתיה אלא

Let us return to our discourse, for from the words of the Midrashim it becomes clear that our first father [Adam] was worthy to also rectify and elevate with his power this lower governance, but he consumed it prematurely. Through that eating, he was prepared to go from strength to strength and to reach, in body and soul, the Eden where there is no eating or drinking, but only enjoyment of the radiance of the Divine Presence. But after the sin, the melting 5R

[1]This presents the radical kabbalistic idea that those who have mastered repentance (בעלי תשובה) have a spiritual advantage over even the naturally righteous, as they can access divine illumination continuously rather than only during sacred times.

[2]The metaphor of being a 'chariot' (מרכבה/merkavah) refers to becoming a perfect vehicle for divine presence. While most individuals embody only aspects of divine attributes, Moses is described as embodying complete divine expression.

[3]This reflects the kabbalistic concept of גלגול (gilgul/reincarnation) and נצוצות (nitzutzot/sparks), suggesting that aspects of Moses' soul are distributed throughout history to spiritually elevate Torah scholars.

[i]Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The text draws extensively from Tikkunei Zohar, a central kabbalistic work that offers mystical interpretations of Torah passages. The author uses these references to develop a complex mystical explanation of Adam's sin involving the different worlds of creation (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) and divine emanations (sefirot). | Cf. Bereishit Rabbah — The author cites this midrashic text to support the interpretation of the forbidden fruit as a fig, providing different rabbinic opinions about the nature of this fig and harmonizing them within a kabbalistic framework of the spiritual worlds. | Cf. Genesis 2-3 — The entire passage is a mystical interpretation of the Garden of Eden narrative, particularly focusing on the nature of the forbidden fruit, the Tree of Knowledge, and the spiritual consequences of Adam's sin across multiple spiritual worlds. | Cf. Proverbs 5:3 — The text references 'For the lips of a strange woman drip honey' to illustrate the deceptive nature of forbidden knowledge, comparing the allure of sin to the seductive appearance of evil that conceals its destructive consequences. | Cf. Deuteronomy 33:21 — The phrase 'he saw the first for himself' alludes to this verse which was originally about Moses, reinforcing the kabbalistic teaching that Moses contained elements of Adam's soul and represented a spiritual rectification of Adam's sin.

[ii]The phrase refers to eating fruit before it has ripened, used as a metaphor for Adam acting prematurely before the proper time for his spiritual elevation.

ההנאה מזיו השכינה. אבל אחר
החטא התמידה ההתכה בכל יום
ואין המזון תמורה מספקת וכ״ש
בהיותו יגע בו אלא לסעדו לחיי
שעה עד שהגיע לגויעה בסוף
ימיו לכלה הפשע ולהתם חטאת
ולהביא צדק עולמים. ובתקון
ס״ד אמרו דחטא אדם היה
תלוי בת״ת וחטא חוה בשכינתא
ונתקללה הארץ שהיה לה למחות
בידו דכתיב ה׳ בחכמה יסד
ארץ. ושם פירש טעם השתנות
טבע האדם ובתקון ס״ט פירש
כי שתי חוות היו חד מגרמא
שהחטיאו וחד מבשרא סוד
יצר הרע ויצר הטוב.[i] ואמרו
בתוספתא בפ׳ וארא שמסטרא
דאילנא דחיי כל דינין מתהפכין
לרחמי ומסטרא דעץ הדעת טוב
ורע כל רחמי מתהפכן לדינא.
וכל מיני אסורין ואכילות
אסורות היו באכילת עץ ההוא
ולזה אמרו שעבר על ע״א ג״ע
וש״ד שלכן הוצרכו ג׳ האבות
למתק ג׳ עבירות אלו ועל כן
פה שאכל נבלות לא יהיה ראוי
לאכול מעץ החיים ח״ו כי בזה
יתן חיות וקיום לחצונים וטמאים
אלא צריך לירד לעפר בגין
דיתמחי יצר הרע דבגוה. הנה כי
אבינו הראשון ירד למקום הדין
למתקו[ii] ולא עלה בידו. וחנוך
זכה לירש נשמה עליונה שהפסיד
אדם הראשון כמו שנתבאר
בזהר שיר השירים. ולבן רוחו

[of his body] continued every day, and food was not sufficient compensation, especially when he labored for it, serving only to sustain his temporal life until he reached his demise at the end of his days, to complete the transgression, to end sin, and to bring everlasting righteousness.[2]

In Tikkun 64, they said that Adam's sin was connected to Tiferet and Eve's sin to the Shekhinah, and the earth was cursed because it should have protested against him, as it is written, "The Lord founded the earth with wisdom." And there it explains the reason for the change in human nature, and in Tikkun 69 it explains that there were two Eves, one from bone who caused him to sin and one from flesh,[1] representing the mystery of the evil inclination and the good inclination.

They said in the Tosefta in Parashat Va'era that from the side of the Tree of Life, all judgments are transformed into mercy, but from the side of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, all mercy is transformed into judgment. All types of prohibitions and forbidden foods were included in the eating of that tree, which is why they said that Adam transgressed idolatry, forbidden sexual relations, and bloodshed. Therefore, the three Patriarchs were needed to sweeten these three transgressions.[2] Consequently, a mouth that has eaten forbidden foods should not be allowed to eat from the Tree of Life, God forbid, because this would give vitality and sustenance to the external forces and impure entities. Rather, one must descend to dust so that the evil inclination within will be erased.

Behold, our first father descended to the place of judgment to sweeten it, but he did not succeed.

[1] This phrase echoes Daniel 9:24, connecting Adam's death to a cosmic process of rectification that culminates in eschatological redemption.

[2] This mysterious reference to 'two Eves' reflects an esoteric kabbalistic teaching found in later mystical texts. It suggests a dualistic nature within Eve herself, representing both the impulse toward sin (from bone) and toward goodness (from flesh).

[3] The text establishes a correspondence between the three cardinal sins (idolatry, forbidden sexual relations, and bloodshed) supposedly committed through Adam's eating from the Tree of Knowledge, and the three Patriarchs who each rectified a different aspect of this sin.

[ii] This refers to an esoteric kabbalistic teaching that there were two Eves—one formed from bone who led Adam to sin, and another from flesh, symbolizing the dual nature of evil and good inclinations. This concept appears in certain Zoharic and later kabbalistic writings.

[i] The kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgment' (המתקת הדינים) refers to transforming harsh divine judgments into mercy through spiritual actions. The text suggests Adam attempted this but failed, while later figures succeeded.

שהיה לו לעמוד בג״ע של מטה
כשאר רוחות הצדיקים זכה
לעלות ולהיות מלאך שר הפנים
לקבל השפע היורד מהכסא
ולחלקו לכל שאר המלאכים
והעולמות. ועוד גופו הגשמי
נהפך ללפידי אש[i] ועלה עם
רוחו להיות מלאך ובזה ירש
מקומו של אדם הראשון שעקר
בריאת אדם היה שיהיה מקור
לכל השפע המתחלק לעליונים
ותחתונים ולהשפיע ממנו להם
עד שכלם היו רוצים להוריד
לו השפע בהשתחויתם לו והוא
הודיעם כי ראוי להמשיך מן
המקור האמיתי ולהיותו מקור
השפע בחטאו גרם מיתה לו ולכל
הנבראים גם כן. דוגמא לחטא
אדם היה חטא נח בשתייתו מהיין
כי נהפך לו לסורי הגפן נבריה
ונשתכר. ואמרו בפ׳ פקודי
בהיכל ראשון כי נכנס להיכלות
הטומאה.[ii] והושע ירא להסתכל
בהיכלות שנדבקו בהם ישראל
עד שהורשה מהקב״ה ואמר לו
לך קח לך אשת זנונים. וכן חטא
בני אהרן בהקריבם אש זרה
כנדרש בכמה מקומות מהזהר.
אך אברהם שהיה ראשון לאבות
העולם לתקון עון אדם הראשון
לכן הושלך לכבשן האש לכפר
על עון ע״א שהיה נכלל בעונו
של אדם וקיים בעצמו פסילי
אלהיהם תשרפון באש. ואח״כ
ירד למצרים ערות הארץ עומק
הקליפות ונכנס בה בשלום ויצא
בשלום והתחיל להוציא את
בלעם מפיהם נשמות הקדושות
שהיו עשוקות בעמקם. וזהו
ואברם כבד מאד במקנה וגו׳

Enoch, however, merited to inherit the supernal soul that Adam lost, as explained in the Zohar on Song of Songs. Therefore, his spirit, which should have remained in the lower Garden of Eden like other spirits of the righteous, merited to ascend and become an angel, the Prince of the Face,[3] to receive the divine flow descending from the Throne and distribute it to all other angels and worlds. Furthermore, his physical body was transformed into torches of fire and ascended with his spirit to become an angel, thereby inheriting Adam's place. For the essential purpose of Adam's creation was that he should be a source for all the divine flow distributed to the upper and lower realms, influencing them to the extent that all [the angels] wanted to direct the flow to him through their prostration before him. But Adam informed them that it was proper to draw from the true Source. By being the source of divine flow and then sinning, he caused death to himself and to all creatures as well.

An example similar to Adam's sin was Noah's sin in drinking wine, as it turned for him into a foreign vine, and he became drunk. They said in Pekudei regarding the first palace that he entered the palaces of impurity. And Hosea was afraid to look at the palaces to which Israel had clung until he was permitted by the Holy One, blessed be He, who said to him, "Go, take for yourself a wife of harlotry." Similarly, the sin of Aaron's sons in offering strange fire, as expounded in several places in the Zohar.

However, Abraham, who was the first of the Patriarchs to rectify the sin of Adam, was thrown into the fiery furnace to atone for the sin of idolatry that was included in Adam's transgression, thereby fulfilling in himself [the commandment], "Burn their idols with fire." Afterward, he descended to Egypt, the nakedness of the land, the depth of the kelipot [negative spiritual forces], entered in peace and departed in peace, and began to extract from their mouths the holy souls that were oppressed in their depths. This is the meaning of "And Abram was very rich

[1] This refers to the Jewish mystical tradition that Enoch was transformed into the angel Metatron, called 'Prince of the Face' (Sar ha-Panim) because he stands directly before God's throne. The text suggests Enoch reclaimed the exalted position that Adam was originally meant to occupy.

[ii] The transformation of Enoch's physical body into 'torches of fire' reflects the mystical tradition that Enoch was transformed into the angel Metatron, representing complete spiritual elevation without death in the ordinary sense.

[iii] The reference to Noah entering 'palaces of impurity' comes from the Zohar's interpretation of his drunkenness as a spiritual descent into negative realms, parallel to Adam's original sin.

ומשם חזר למסעיו מנגב ועד בית
אל. ויצחק נתעצם מאד מארץ
פלשתים וזהו שדרשו על פסוק
כי עצמת ממנו. וכן עשה יעקב
שגנב לבו של לבן הארמי. ירצה
תוכו ופנימיותו וחיותו שגזלו
החצונים בחטא הקדום דוגמא
לזה ד׳ נכנסו לפרדס ואחד
מהם יצא בשלום.[iii] והדרוש
הלז נתבאר אצלנו באור רחב
במקום כבודו. וריש מלין לבד
העלינו פה לבל יאשם אבינו
הראשון בתחלת מחשבתו כי חשב
להרבות כבוד עליון בגולות
עליות וגולות תחתיות וחסיד
גדול היה ועיין בפ״ב מחלק
ד׳ ביצד היה דבורו של נחש
עם חוה וטענה נצחת להענש
אדם על ידו. עוד שם פרק ט׳
מחלק ג׳ ביאר ביצד נכנס יצר
הרע באדם כי האלהים עשה
את האדם ישר. ואמרו בתקונים
וגם בפרקי היכלות כי אז ס״מ
בעט באדוניו ויצא להתרבות רעה
והוא שטן הוא יצה״ר הוא מלאך
המות או בחותיו הם. נקרא
מלא עינים[i] המתראה לנגד מזלו
של אדם בדאמרן שמתחלה היה
אחד מהשרפים בעלי שש כנפים.
ואם האדם בעה״ז מגביר הטוב
ע״י עבודתו משבר ומכתת כח
החצונים וזהו הוא ישופך ראש
אפי׳ בבחינה עליונה בחצוניותם
מלבד המתקן הדינין הקדושים
שרשי שרשם אמנם אם שומע לו
תשופנו עקב סוף המות ואחריתו
לנפול בידו לכן אמרי טוב
שבנחשים רצוץ את מוחו. וכן כל
המחניף לרשע סופו נופל בידו

in livestock," etc., and from there he returned to his journeys from the Negev to Bethel. Isaac gained great strength from the land of the Philistines, which is what they expounded on the verse, "For you have become much mightier than we." Similarly, Jacob stole the heart of Laban the Aramean—meaning his inner essence and vitality that the external forces had stolen in the primordial sin. This is analogous to the four who entered the Pardes [mystical orchard], and only one of them emerged in peace.

This discourse has been explained by us at length elsewhere. We have raised just the beginning of these matters here so that our first father should not be blamed for his initial thought, for he intended to increase the glory of the Most High through the exile of the upper [worlds] and the exile of the lower [worlds], and he was a great pious one. See Chapter 2 of Part 4 on how the serpent's speech with Eve contained an irrefutable argument for Adam to be punished through it. Also, Chapter 9 of Part 3 explains how the evil inclination entered Adam, for God made man upright. They said in the Tikkunim and also in Pirkei Heikhalot that at that time, Samael rebelled against his master and turned to evil ways, and he is Satan, he is the evil inclination, he is the Angel of Death, or they are his forces. He is called "full of eyes," appearing against a person's mazal [spiritual destiny], as we have said, for initially he was one of the seraphim with six wings.

If a person in this world strengthens the good through his service, he breaks and crushes the power of the external forces, and this is [the meaning of] "He shall bruise your head," even in the higher aspect of their externality, apart from rectifying the holy judgments at their root of roots. However, if one listens to [the evil inclination], "You shall bruise his heel"—ultimately death and his end will be to fall into its hand. Therefore, they said, "The best of snakes—crush its head."[1] Similarly, whoever flatters

[1]The Hebrew phrase 'רצוץ את מוחו' (crush its head) reflects rabbinic wisdom about dealing with the evil inclination, linking to Genesis 3:15 where God tells the serpent that the human seed 'shall

[i]This refers to the famous Talmudic story (Chagigah 14b) of four sages who entered the mystical orchard (PaRDeS): Ben Azzai, Ben Zoma, Acher (Elisha ben Avuya), and Rabbi Akiva, with only Rabbi Akiva emerging unharmed. The author uses this as an analogy for those who attempt to rectify Adam's sin by entering spiritual realms.

[ii]The phrase 'full of eyes' refers to the traditional depiction of certain angelic beings covered with eyes, symbolizing divine providence and awareness. Here it is applied to Samael as the Angel of Death who constantly watches humans.

טב לביש וגו׳ וכדומה. ועתה
125 שחוה ירדה אל העצב יש צער
לגדל הבנים כי צריך להעלותו
מעט מעט משפלת עמק המצב אל
מקום הקדש שהוא כצמח שתחת
האבן שצריך דוחק גדול עד
130 שיבקע האבן. כך אבן נגף דוחק
התינוק עד שיבקע הקליפה
ויתעלה מעט מעט יוצא מתחת יד
אסכרא אל תחת יד סכנה אחרת.
ואחר כך אל תחת יד מלאך
135 המות. ולזה אחרית הכל המות
וזה מחמת לבושי עור הנחש הזה
הכרוך עלינו. והנה כבר יצאנו
מכוונת דרושנו לכבוד אבינו
הראשון: [i]

the wicked will ultimately fall into his hand—"good for the wicked," etc., and the like. 125R

Now that Eve has descended into sorrow, there is pain in raising children, for one must elevate them little by little from the lowliness of their condition to the holy place. This is like a plant under a stone that needs great pressure until it breaks through the 130R stone. Similarly, a stumbling block presses upon the child until he breaks through the shell and ascends gradually, emerging from under the hand of diphtheria to under the hand of another danger,[1] and afterward to under the hand of the Angel of Death. 135R Therefore, the end of everything is death, and this is due to the garments of skin of this serpent that is wrapped around us. We have already departed from the intention of our discourse in honor of our first father. 140R

פרק ל״ד

Chapter 34

אמרו החכמים כי בשעת פטירתו
של אדם רשע המלאך הממונה על
הדין עומד כנגדו ואומר אוי על
זה הגוף שיצא מן העולם ריקם
5 מזכיות ומלא עונות. וכתבו
בתקונים דף ס״ד כי הנחש הורג

The Sages taught that at the moment of a wicked person's death, the angel appointed over judgment stands before him[2] and says: "Woe to this body that departs from the world empty of merits and full of sins." And it is written in Tikkunim, page 64, 5R that the serpent kills human beings and inevitably

bruise your head.' The text develops this metaphor to explain how righteous service crushes evil spiritual forces.

[2]This poignant description of childhood development portrays each stage of growth as emerging from one danger only to face another, culminating ultimately in death. The reference to diphtheria (אסכרא) reflects ancient and medieval understanding of this often-fatal childhood disease.

[3]The text describes a spiritual process that occurs at the moment of death, when the forces of judgment evaluate the spiritual status of the departing soul.

[i]Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The text cites specific sections of the Tikkunei Zohar to explain the kabbalistic understanding of Adam and Eve's sin. Tikkun 64 connects Adam's sin to the sefirah of Tiferet and Eve's to the Shekhinah, while Tikkun 69 presents the esoteric concept of two Eves representing good and evil inclinations. | Cf. Zohar on Song of Songs — The text references the Zohar on Song of Songs regarding Enoch inheriting Adam's supernal soul. This reference supports the passage's kabbalistic interpretation of how Enoch achieved angelic status by reclaiming what Adam lost through sin. | Cf. The story of the four who entered Pardes — The author compares the Patriarchs' spiritual rectifications to the famous Talmudic tale of four sages who entered the mystical orchard (Pardes), where only Rabbi Akiva emerged unharmed. This analogy suggests that entering spiritual realms to recover what was lost in Adam's sin requires special merit and protection. | Cf. Pirkei Heikhalot — The text cites Pirkei Heikhalot alongside Tikkunim regarding Samael's rebellion. This reference to the early mystical Heikhalot literature establishes a connection between medieval Kabbalah and earlier Jewish mystical traditions regarding the nature of evil spiritual forces. | Cf. Zohar Pekudei — The text cites the Zohar portion of Pekudei regarding Noah entering palaces of impurity, establishing a pattern of sin parallel to Adam's. This reference supports the passage's theme of how righteous figures after Adam either repeated or rectified aspects of the original sin.

בני אדם וגורם הדמעה עכ״פ
והורג בסם המות שלו שהוא
גיהנם ודא איהו ס״מ. ואינו זז
מן האדם עד שיכלה בעפר כי 10R
בשרו הוא מעורו ומארבעה מיני
צרעת שהם בנחש נובעים מהם
ד׳ מיני חולאים שהם מרה לבנה.
מרה אדומה מרה ירוקה מרה
שחורה. וכתוב בתקון כ׳ דף 15R
מ״ב ע״ב בר נש בהאי עלמא איהו
צרעת ממשבא דחויא. וזה הראה
הקב״ה למשה בסנה שאמר לו אל
תקרב הלם עד שיופשט מהגוף
שהלבישה אותו בת פרעה שהיא 20R
נטהרה בנגיעתה למשה ונתרפאת
מצרעתה. ומשה אז נצטרע כי
פרחה ממנו שבינה. והיה זה
דוגמת פרה אדומה המטהרת
הטמאים מצד ימין ומטמאת 25R
הטהורים מצד שמאל שלה
דמסטרה ס״מ שנפל מקדושתו.
ואחר שנתפשט מאותו הגוף
וחזר לג״ע נתלבש בגוף קדוש
שלו וזהו והנה שבה כבשרו. 30R
וכן האדם אם שב בתשובה
יורד עליו סם חיים לרפואתו.
וכתב בעל ראשית חכמה כי
הנשמה נדונת בדקדוק גמור
אחר פטירתה ומביא מעשים 35R
על זה וזהו אצלי זכר רחמיך
ה׳ וחסדיך כי מעולם המה.
ירצה כי ורחמים והחסדים הם
מתנהגים עם האדם בעולם הזה
שהוא עולם המעשה והתשובה. 40R
וכן אברהם ויעקב שהיו בע״הז
היו מרכבה לרחמים וחסדים
וזהו כי מעולם המה. ולכן ביד
החוטא לתקן מה שעוות ומעט
יסורין ימרקו לו הרבה. אבל 45R
בעולם הגמול אין הנשמה יכולה
לעלות בצרור עליון והרוח
בג״ע של מטה והנפש אינה יכולה

causes tears,[3] and kills with its deadly poison, which is Gehenna—and this is Samael. It does not leave a person until he decomposes in the dust, for his flesh comes from the serpent's skin. From the four types of leprosy that exist in the serpent flow four types of illnesses: white bile, red bile, green bile, and black bile. And it is written in Tikkun 20, page 42b: "A human being in this world is leprosy from the skin of the serpent." This is what the Holy One, blessed be He, showed Moses at the burning bush[1] when He told him, "Do not come closer," until he would be stripped of the body that Pharaoh's daughter had clothed him with—for she was purified through her contact with Moses and was healed of her leprosy. Moses then became leprous because the Divine Presence departed from him. This was similar to the red heifer that purifies the impure from its right side while making the pure impure from its left side, which is from the side of Samael who fell from his holiness. After Moses was stripped of that body and returned to the Garden of Eden, he was clothed in his holy body, and this is the meaning of "behold, it was restored like his flesh." Similarly, if a person repents, the elixir of life descends upon him for his healing.

The author of Reshit Chochmah wrote that the soul is judged with absolute precision after its departure and brings evidence for this from the verse: "Remember Your mercies, O LORD, and Your kindnesses, for they have existed from eternity." This means that mercy and kindness govern a person's existence in this world, which is the world of action and repentance. Thus, Abraham and Jacob, who lived in this world, were vehicles for mercy and kindness, and this is the meaning of "for they have existed from eternity." Therefore, it is within a sinner's power to correct what he has distorted, and a small amount of suffering will purify a great deal for him.

But in the world of recompense, the soul cannot ascend to the supernal bond, nor can the spirit ascend to the lower Garden of Eden,[2] nor can the vital soul delight in the radiance of its soul in the

[1] In kabbalistic thought, the 'serpent' represents the primordial force of evil and death (often associated with the biblical serpent from the Garden of Eden), which introduced mortality to humanity.

[2] This passage offers a mystical interpretation of the burning bush narrative from Exodus 3, suggesting that Moses needed spiritual purification before approaching the divine revelation.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that the different components of the soul ascend to different spiritual realms after death, with the highest (neshamah) reaching the 'supernal bond,' the middle

להתעדן בצחצחות נפשה בסוד
לבוש הראוי לה דמתחזי ולא
מתחזי עד כי יתלבנו ויצטרפו
שלשתן יחד מכל וכל כי כל אשר
בו מום לא יקרב וכל היסורים
והנגעים וכ״ש יום המיתה כלם
ודאי טהרה הם מצד האש. וטבע
האש ללבן מבית ומחוץ כפגם
שהרתיח עצמו באש היצר כן
צריך הטהרה והליבון. ולכן
התענית הוא אש מטהר לאש
היצר מצד ענוי נפשו והתכת
חלבו ודמו. ואמרו בפ׳ שמות
דף י״ג בסוד עדון הרוח בג״ע
תחתון דכמה דגופא אתהני בהאי
עלמא מקטורא דארבע יסודות
ומצטייר בהאי עלמא אוף
הכי רוחא קיימא בג״ע תתאה
בדיוקנא דהאי עלמא וחדאן
ברוחיהון דצדיקייא דעאלין
תמן ואינון רוחין מצטיירין תמן
מקטורא דארבע רוחין דקיימא
בגנתא. ואלמלא אינון ד׳ רוחין
דאינון אוירא דגנתא רוחא לא
מצטיירא בציורא כלל ולא
אתלבשא בהו בגין כך כתיב
מארבע רוחות בואי הרוח: [i]

secret of the appropriate garment that is visible yet not visible, until all three are purified and refined together completely. For "anything with a blemish shall not approach," and all sufferings and afflictions—especially the day of death—are certainly forms of purification through fire. The nature of fire is to whiten from within and without; just as one inflamed himself with the fire of desire, so does he require purification and whitening. Therefore, fasting is a purifying fire for the fire of desire,[1] as it causes affliction to one's soul and melts one's fat and blood.

And they said in Parshat Shemot, page 13, concerning the delight of the spirit in the lower Garden of Eden: "Just as the body benefits in this world from the bond of the four elements and takes form in this world, so too does the spirit exist in the lower Garden of Eden in the likeness of this world,[2] and they rejoice with the spirits of the righteous who enter there. Those spirits take form there from the bond of the four winds that exist in the garden. Were it not for those four winds, which are the air of the garden, the spirit would not take form at all and would not be clothed in them. Therefore it is written: 'From the four winds, come, O spirit.'[3]"

(ruach) dwelling in the Garden of Eden, and the lowest (nefesh) remaining connected to the grave until the body decomposes.

[2]This reflects the ascetic dimension of Jewish mystical practice, where physical self-denial (particularly fasting) is understood as a means of spiritual purification and atonement.

[3]This presents a conception of the afterlife where the human spirit maintains a form resembling its earthly appearance but constituted from spiritual rather than physical elements.

[4]This is a reference to Ezekiel 37:9, from the prophet's vision of the valley of dry bones, which describes resurrection. Here it's applied to the formation of the spiritual body in the afterlife.

[i]Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This reference establishes the kabbalistic understanding of how spiritual impurity (symbolized by the serpent) affects the physical body during life and after death. The serpent represents Samael, the angel of death, who clings to the human form until complete decomposition. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This reinforces the kabbalistic concept that the physical body itself is a manifestation of spiritual impurity derived from the primordial serpent, explaining why it must decompose after death. | Cf. Exodus 3:5 — The text presents a mystical interpretation of the burning bush incident, suggesting Moses needed to be stripped of physical impurity (likened to leprosy) before approaching the divine. This creates a parallel between physical purification and spiritual elevation. | Cf. Reshit Chochmah — This kabbalistic work by Rabbi Eliyahu de Vidas is cited to establish the contrast between this world (governed by mercy) and the World to Come (governed by strict justice), explaining why repentance must occur before death. | Cf. Zohar — This Zoharic passage explains the structural correspondence between physical and spiritual bodies, describing how the spirit maintains a form in the afterlife that resembles its earthly appearance but is composed of spiritual 'elements.' | Cf. Four humors theory — The text integrates medieval medical theory of the four humors with kabbalistic concepts, connecting physical illness to spiritual impurity derived from the primordial serpent. | Cf. Ezekiel 37:9 — This biblical

פרק ל״ה

Chapter 35

כוונה נאותה[ii] לעומד בעת סלוק נשמה מאחד מצדיקים[i] ובזה מסייע לו להצילו מרעהו[iii ii]

An appropriate intention[A] for one who stands present at the departure of a soul[A] from one of the righteous, and through this assists in saving him from his adversary[B]

לנו הורו גאוני עולם כי שבירת כלים העליונים הנקראים בספרא דצניעותא מלכין קדמאין[iv] אינו רק חזרת האור והנשמה למקומה למעלה להיות הכלי קטן מהכיל רוב האור מחמת המיעוט הצפוי בתחלת המחשבה. וירידת הכלים למטה שמהם שרש הקליפות ובשברים אלו נשארו נצוצי טהרה[v] בקיתון שמן זית שנשבר. ובקפול רגלי אריך אנפין[vi] הועלה הסלת

The great scholars of the world have taught us that the breaking of the supernal vessels,[1] referred to in the Safra D'Tzniuta as "primordial kings," is merely the return of light and soul to its place above, as the vessel was too small to contain the abundance of light due to the contraction foreseen in the initial thought. The vessels descended below, becoming the root of the kelipot (negative forces), yet within these broken fragments remained sparks of purity, like a jug of olive oil that has shattered. When Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One) folded His legs, the pure flour was elevated from these remnants, while the remnants of

[C] Or: "proper mystical meditation" — This alternate emphasizes the kabbalistic dimension of 'kavvanah' as a specific type of focused mystical consciousness rather than just a general 'intention.'

[D] Or: "for one who is present during the soul's departure" — This provides a slightly more natural English phrasing while preserving the meaning.

[E] Or: "to rescue him from his spiritual prosecutor" — This alternate more explicitly identifies the 'adversary' as a spiritual prosecutor, which better reflects the kabbalistic understanding of the forces confronting the soul at death.

[1] This translation addresses one of the most complex concepts in Lurianic Kabbalah, the 'Breaking of the Vessels' (Shevirat ha-Kelim). The passage presents a particular interpretation of this concept, emphasizing that the breaking wasn't a catastrophic failure but a necessary process for divine light to return to its source.

allusion to Ezekiel's vision of the dry bones is repurposed to explain how souls take form in the Garden of Eden, suggesting a parallel between resurrection and the soul's afterlife existence.

[i] The term 'kavvanah' (mystical intention) refers to a focused meditative state of consciousness directed toward a specific spiritual purpose. In Kabbalah, having the proper kavvanah was considered essential for efficacy of prayers and rituals.

[ii] The departure of the soul of a righteous person was considered a particularly significant spiritual moment in Jewish mystical tradition. The text implies that proper intention from those present could affect the soul's journey.

[iii] In kabbalistic thought, the soul faces various spiritual adversaries or accusers at the time of death. These may include the Angel of Death (malakh ha-mavet), negative spiritual forces (kelipot), or spiritual prosecutors (kategor).

[iv] Cf. Zohar — This passage draws on Zoharic concepts of how the righteous soul faces judgment at death, and how proper intention from the living can assist in this transition. | Cf. Earlier sections of Ma'avar Yabok — This passage continues the book's theme of providing specific spiritual tools for those present at deathbeds, emphasizing that their proper focus can actively assist the soul.

[v] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the 'Breaking of the Vessels' (Shevirat ha-Kelim), a foundational doctrine in Lurianic Kabbalah describing how the primordial vessels meant to contain divine light shattered because they were unable to contain the powerful divine light, causing sparks of divinity to be scattered and trapped in the material world.

[vi] These are the 'sparks of purity' or divine sparks that fell and became embedded in the material world after the Breaking of the Vessels. In Kabbalistic thought, one of humanity's spiritual tasks is to elevate these sparks back to their divine source through religious devotion and righteous acts.

נקייה משיריים אלו ושירי
שיריים נשארו להיות חיות
לקליפות. ובכח תפלתנו וכ״ש
בסלוק נשמותיהם של צדיקים
עם צירוף כל המצות שפעל
ועשה שם בחייו דבר יום ביומו
מדי עבור נשמות אלו דרך עולם
העשייה מעלין נצוצי טהרה
שבתוך הקליפות לעולם היצירה
וכן מיצירה לבריאה ומבריאה
לאצילות. ומרשימו של שש
קצוות עולים שלש ראשונות
עד שחוזרים האורות למקומם
וזהו סוד מיין נוקבין[i] הנעשים
ע״י נשמות הצדיקים ובפרט
מאותם המתים לכבוד השם.
ונפשות הצדיקים נעשים מיין
נוקבין לזווג ת״ת ומלכות. ות״ת
ומלכות נעשים מיין נוקבין
לזווג חכמה ובינה וכזה תהיה
כוונת מסירת נפש האדם בנפילת
אפים[ii] והמבין בה כראוי זוכה
למעלות רבות הא׳ שנעשה
כבריה חדשה שכבר נפטר הגוף
הראשון וזה גוף חדש כי נפש״י

remnants remained to give life to the kelipot.

Through the power of our prayers, and especially through the departure of the souls of the righteous—combined with all the commandments they performed and fulfilled during their lifetime, day by day—as these souls pass through the World of Action (Asiyah), they elevate the sparks of purity contained within the kelipot[1] to the World of Formation (Yetzirah), and likewise from Formation to Creation (Beriah), and from Creation to Emanation (Atzilut). From the impression of the six directions, the three highest sefirot rise until the lights return to their place. This is the secret of the feminine waters (mayin nukvin)[2] created through the souls of the righteous, particularly those who die for the sanctification of the Divine Name.

The souls of the righteous become feminine waters for the union of Tiferet and Malkhut, and Tiferet and Malkhut in turn become feminine waters for the union of Chokhmah and Binah. This same intention should be present when one surrenders their soul during prostration in prayer (nefilat apayim).[3] One who focuses properly on this gains many spiritual benefits:[4] First, one becomes like a new creation, as their first body has already departed and this is

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'birur' (clarification or sifting), where divine sparks trapped in the material realm are elevated through religious observance. The text specifically connects this process to the death of righteous individuals, suggesting their passing creates a powerful opportunity for such elevation.

[2] I've translated 'mayin nukvin' both literally and with its technical kabbalistic meaning. This concept is central to understanding the cosmic dynamics described in the passage, where desire and arousal from below (the feminine) stimulates flow from above (the masculine).

[3] This specific prayer practice involves falling on one's face in complete submission. The passage makes the remarkable claim that proper intention during this prayer ritual can simulate the spiritual benefits of death without actually dying, creating a kind of mystical rehearsal for the soul's final ascent.

[4] The text enumerates eight specific benefits of properly performing the prostration prayer with correct mystical intention. This structured presentation of benefits follows a pattern common in ethical and mystical Jewish literature, making abstract mystical concepts more accessible through practical outcomes.

[i] Literally 'the folding of the legs of Arich Anpin.' Arich Anpin (Long-Faced One) is a Partzuf (divine persona) in Kabbalah representing the divine attribute of Keter (Crown) in its aspect of divine will and mercy. The 'folding of the legs' is a metaphorical description of how divine emanation is restricted or limited as it descends into lower spiritual worlds.

[ii] Literally 'feminine waters,' this is a kabbalistic concept referring to the spiritual arousal or desire that ascends from below (the feminine principle) to stimulate a reciprocal flow of divine abundance from above (the masculine principle). This forms part of the mystical understanding of cosmic unions between divine attributes.

[iii] A prayer practice involving prostration or bowing with the face to the ground, particularly during the Tachanun section of Jewish liturgy. In Kabbalistic understanding, this posture symbolizes complete self-nullification and surrender before God, with mystical significance for the soul's elevation.

בגי׳ מ״ת.[iii] הב׳ תוספת אומץ
ללחום נגד יצה״ר. הג׳ תוספת
השכלה בסודות התורה. הד׳
תוספת דבקות בקונו. הה׳ שעל
ידי כך הוא עושה מסילה שמורה
לו כשיפטר מן העולם. הו׳ גורם
השפעה לכנסת ישראל שאומרת
תן לי בשביל בני זה. הז׳ אין
חטא בא לידו. ואם יזדמן לו
יתיסר בעה״ז עד שיתמרק. הח׳
זוכה לעלות נשמתו תכף בלי
עכוב. עוד בנפילת אפים אנו
מעוררים זעיר ונוקביה[i] ובגידול
זעיר המרים ראשו אז מחזיר
מאור חכמה למעלה שירד אורה
בעת מעוטה וזה כדי לקבל
חלק מהאור שירד אליה מתחלה
לבד באופן שיוכלו התחתונים
ליהנות ממנה ולא יכהו עיניהם
מרוב האורות כבתחלה דמלכין
קדמאין אצטנעו מרוב האורות
ואורם ירד למטה עד גבול
האצילות ולא יותר ח״ו.
ונוקביה דזעיר בהיותה עולה
עמו וכ״ש בהיותה עטרת בעלה
מעלה מאור שירד מבינה
כשנתמעטה שהיא ג״כ ירדה
עד סוף האצילות לא למטה.
א״כ העלאת הנובלות מסורות
בידינו כי אנחנו מעוררים זעיר
ונוקביה לעומת אבא ואמא
ולדרך כוונה זו מסוגל פסוק
שמע ישראל וברוך שם כבוד
מלכותו לעולם ועד וגם שם מ״ב
שעולה ואינו יורד[ii] ומבקשי ה׳
יבינו כל. ובכוונה זו הבטיח

a new body, for "my soul" (nafshi) has the numerical value of "dead" (met). Second, one gains additional strength to battle against the evil inclination. Third, one gains additional insight into the secrets of Torah. Fourth, one experiences increased attachment to one's Creator. Fifth, through this practice, one creates a protected pathway for when they depart from the world. Sixth, one causes an influx of divine flow to the Community of Israel,[1] which says, "Give to me for the sake of this child of mine." Seventh, sin will not come into one's hand, and if it should happen, one will be disciplined in this world until purified. Eighth, one merits the immediate ascent of their soul without delay.

Furthermore, during prostration we arouse Zeir Anpin (the Small-Faced One) and His female counterpart, and when Zeir Anpin grows and raises His head, He then returns the light of Wisdom above, whose light descended during the time of diminishment. This is in order to receive only a portion of the light that initially descended to her, in a way that allows the lower realms to benefit from it without their eyes being blinded by the abundance of light as at the beginning, when the primordial kings were concealed due to the abundance of light, and their light descended below to the boundary of Atzilut but no further, God forbid. When the female aspect of Zeir Anpin ascends with Him, especially when she becomes her husband's crown, she elevates the light that descended from Binah when it was diminished, which itself had descended only to the end of Atzilut but not below.

Thus, the elevation of the fallen remnants is entrusted to our hands, for we arouse Zeir Anpin and His female counterpart toward Father and Mother. The verse "Hear, O Israel" and "Blessed

[1] In Kabbalistic symbolism, 'Knesset Yisrael' (Community of Israel) often represents the Shekhinah or divine feminine presence. The passage suggests that proper prayer creates a flow of divine energy not just for the individual but for the entire mystical body of Israel.

[i] This indicates a gematria (numerical equivalence): the Hebrew word 'nafshi' (my soul) has the same numerical value as 'met' (dead)—both equal 440. This wordplay supports the kabbalistic concept that self-nullification in prayer is a kind of spiritual death and rebirth.

[ii] Zeir Anpin (Small-Faced One) and His female counterpart (Nukvah) are Partzufim (divine personas) in Kabbalah. Zeir Anpin corresponds primarily to the sefirah of Tiferet but encompasses the six sefirot from Chesed through Yesod, while Nukvah corresponds to Malkhut. Their union represents the mystical coupling of divine attributes.

[iii] The 42-letter Divine Name is a mystical name of God formed from various combinations of Hebrew letters. The statement that it 'ascends but does not descend' refers to its unique property of spiritual elevation without subsequent descent, making it particularly powerful for mystical ascent and soul elevation.

הכתוב לעומד בשעת יציאת נשמה מצדיק. ויחי עוד לנצח לא יראה השחת וזה בשכר כי יראה חכמים ימותו:[i] [ii]

be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever" are especially suited for this intention, as is the 42-letter Divine Name which ascends but does not descend[2]—and those who seek the Lord will understand all. With this intention, Scripture promises to one who stands present at the moment a righteous person's soul departs: "He shall live forever and not see destruction," and this is the reward "for he sees that the wise die."[1]

פרק ל״ו

Chapter 36

עוד כוונה למפקיד ביד אל רוחו ונשמתו טוב הדבר מאד להזכיר סמוך לפטירתו למי שזכה לשמש חכמים בחייו ג׳ פסוקים בכוונה. בשנת מות המלך עזיהו ואראה את ה׳ יושב על כסא רם ונשא ושוליו מלאים את ההיכל. שרפים עומדים ממעל לו שש כנפים שש כנפים לאחד בשתים יכסה פניו ובשתים יכסה רגליו ובשתים

Another intention for one who entrusts his spirit and soul to God's hand:[A] it is very beneficial for one who has merited to serve Torah scholars during his lifetime to recite three verses with proper intention near the time of his passing. "In the year that King Uzziah died, I saw the Lord sitting on a throne, high and lifted up, and His train filled the temple. Above it stood seraphim; each one had six wings: with two he covered his face, with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew. And one cried to another and said: 'Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts;

[A] Or: "for one who deposits his spirit and soul in God's hand" — The Hebrew term 'מפקיד' derives from a root meaning 'to deposit' or 'entrust for safekeeping,' suggesting the image of the soul being given to God for safekeeping, like a valuable deposit.

[1] This describes a unique property of the 42-letter Divine Name in kabbalistic thought. Unlike other spiritual forces that may rise and fall, this Name only elevates, making it particularly powerful for the soul's ascent at death.

[2] The passage concludes with this scriptural quote from Psalm 49:11, but reinterprets it in a positive light—suggesting that witnessing the death of righteous individuals with proper mystical intention grants spiritual benefits and protection from seeing destruction.

[i] This phrase concludes the passage with a reference to Psalm 49:11, which discusses how everyone, including the wise, must face death. In the context of this mystical text, it takes on deeper significance about the spiritual elevation possible through properly attending a righteous person's death.

[ii] Cf. Safra D'Tzniuta — The passage cites this authoritative mystical text to establish its discussion of the Breaking of the Vessels, lending legitimacy to its kabbalistic interpretations by grounding them in this canonical source. | Cf. Nefilat Apayim prayer ritual — The text draws a parallel between the mystical significance of death and the ritual practice of falling on one's face in prayer, suggesting this prayer practice can simulate some of the spiritual benefits of death while still alive. | Cf. Psalm 49:11 — The passage reinterprets this verse from its original context about the universality of death to suggest that witnessing the death of the wise with proper mystical intention provides spiritual protection. | Cf. Shema prayer — The text identifies this foundational prayer as particularly suited for the mystical intention of elevating divine sparks, connecting daily liturgical practice with the cosmic process of tikkun (repair). | Cf. 42-letter Divine Name — The passage highlights this powerful divine name as having special properties for soul elevation, particularly relevant at the moment of a righteous person's death. | Cf. Lurianic Kabbalah — While not explicitly mentioned, the entire passage draws heavily on Lurianic kabbalistic concepts including the Breaking of the Vessels, divine sparks, and the structure of spiritual worlds, adapted specifically for the context of death rituals.

יעופף. וקרא זה אל זה ואמר
קדוש קדוש קדוש ה׳ צבאות
מלא כל הארץ כבודו. והם מ״ב
תיבות[iii] מן את עד כבודו ויכוין
אל לבו אם יזכוהו מן השמים
בשם א״ת[i] בללות כל האצילות
מן כתר עליון דאיהו אל״ף עד
המלכות דאיהי תי״ו ונקראת
אדנ״י ולעולם תהיה הכוונה
בעצמות המתפשט בספירות
מכח אין סוף עלת כל העלות
ובאומרו יושב על כסא רם ונשא
יכוין לכסא הכבוד[ii] הנקראים
עשר ספירות דבריאה שהם ענפי
האצילות המתפשטות במדרגות
הבריאה ונכללות ומתלבשות בה
ונקראים כסא הכבוד והמלכות
יושבת על הבריאה עם כל
כללות העשר ספירות דאצילות
הכלולים במלכות. ויען כי כסא
זה של מדרגת הבריאה מתרומם
על ב׳ מדרגות אחרות שתחתיו
והם מדרגת היצירה הנקראת
עולם המלאכים ומדרגת העשיה
דהיינו האופנים ושמים וארץ
על כן אמר ר״ם ונש״א וגם לזה
יכוין. ובאמרו ושוליו מלאים
את ההיכל יכוין אל התפשטות
הבריאה במדרגת היצירה אשר
היא היכל אל הבריאה ובהיכל

the whole earth is full of His glory!'" These verses contain forty-two words from "et" (the) to "kevodo" (His glory), and one should focus his intention, if
15 Heaven grants him merit,[2] on the name AT, which 15R
encompasses all of Atzilut[1] (Emanation), from Keter Elyon (Supreme Crown), which is Aleph, to Malkhut, which is Tav and is called Adonai. Always direct your intention toward the Divine Essence that ex-
20 tends through the sefirot[2] by the power of Ein Sof, 20R
the Cause of all causes.

When reciting "sitting on a throne, high and lifted up," one should direct his intention toward the Throne of Glory, which refers to the ten sefirot
25 of Beriah (Creation) that are branches of Atzilut 25R
extending into the levels of Beriah, included and clothed within it, and are called the Throne of Glory. Malkhut sits upon Beriah together with all the ten sefirot of Atzilut contained within Malkhut.
30 And since this throne of the Beriah level is elevated 30R
above two other levels beneath it—namely, the level of Yetzirah, called the World of Angels, and the level of Asiyah, meaning the Ophanim, heaven, and earth—therefore it says "high and lifted up," and
35 one should also focus on this. 35R

When saying "and His train filled the temple," one should focus on the extension of Beriah into the level of Yetzirah, which is the chamber of Beriah. In this chamber are the angels in ten levels, and the
40 highest level consists of those angels called Seraphim 40R
due to their exalted status, which is the meaning of

[1] The concept of kavvanah (intention or focused concentration) is central to Jewish mystical practice. Here it implies that proper mystical meditation requires both human effort and divine assistance.

[2] Atzilut (Emanation) is the highest of four cosmic worlds in Kabbalistic cosmology, representing the realm of pure divinity. The other three worlds mentioned in the text are Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action).

[3] This references the paradoxical Kabbalistic concept that the infinite divine essence (Ein Sof) both transcends and permeates the ten sefirot (divine emanations or attributes), which serve as channels for divine energy into the created worlds.

[i] The Hebrew term "מ״ב תיבות" (42 words) refers to the forty-two words in the quoted verses from Isaiah's vision. This number has special significance in Jewish mysticism, particularly in relation to the 42-letter Name of God, which is considered one of the most powerful divine names in Kabbalah.

[ii] The "name AT" (א״ת) refers to a conceptual divine name spanning from Aleph (א) to Tav (ת), the first and last letters of the Hebrew alphabet, symbolizing the totality of divine emanation through all levels of existence.

[iii] "Throne of Glory" (כסא הכבוד) is a central concept in Jewish mysticism, representing the interface between the utterly transcendent divine essence and the created worlds. It is described here as corresponding to the world of Beriah (Creation), the second of four cosmic worlds in Kabbalistic cosmology.

זה שם המלאכים בעשרה מדרגות
והמדרגה העליונה הם אותם
המלאכים הנקראים שרפים
למעלתם וזהו אומרו שרפים
עומדים ממעל לו. וכל מדרגה
ומדרגה מעשרה מדרגות אלו
של מלאכים היא נחלקת לשבעה
כתות נגד שבעה ספירות וכנגדן
שבעה שמות של שם מ״ב[i] שש
כנפים לאחד כנגד שש אותיות
שבכל שם מאלו. באומרו פניו
יכוין אל התעלמות השרפים
בבחינת מה שבהם. ובאומרו
רגליו יכוין אל התעלמותם
בבחינת שמשפיעים. ובאומרו
יעופף יכוין אל בחינת מה
שמתנשאים לקבל מלמעלה
ומתוך כך יכוין גם הוא אל
התעופפות נפשו למעלה אל
רום המעלות תחת כסא הכבוד
בכח הכנפים אשר לה דוגמת
השרפים ונעשים לה מרוחניות
שם של מ״ב. וכאן יכוין בו
במחשבה הראשון פת״ח שב״א
פת״ח שב״א פת״ח.[ii] החלק
השני שב״א פת״ח שב״א פת״ח.
השלישי שב״א פת״ח שב״א פת״ח
פת״ח. החלק הרביעי פת״ח
שב״א פת״ח שב״א פת״ח. החלק
החמישי שב״א פת״ח שב״א פת״ח.
החלק הששי קמ״ץ שב״א קמ״ץ
חיר״ק. ויכוין לאות המתדגשת
בדגשותה והרפויה ברפה שלה.
ואח״כ יאמר הפסוק הג׳ וקרא
זה אל זה ואמר. ויכוין בקדוש

"seraphim stood above Him." Each level of these ten levels of angels is divided into seven groups[3] corresponding to the seven sefirot, and corresponding to them are seven names from the 42-letter Name, with "six wings for each one" corresponding to the six letters in each of these names. 45R

When reciting "his face," one should focus on the Seraphim's concealment with respect to their inner essence.[A] When saying "his feet," one should focus on their concealment with respect to how they channel influence downward. And when saying "he flew," one should focus on how they elevate themselves to receive from above. Through this, he should also focus on the ascent of his own soul upward to the highest heights beneath the Throne of Glory, by the power of the wings which his soul has like the Seraphim, which are formed for it from the spirituality of the 42-letter Name. 50R 55R

Here one should focus in thought on the vowelization: the first section—patach, sheva, patach, sheva, patach; the second section—sheva, patach, sheva, patach; the third section—sheva, patach, sheva, patach, patach; the fourth section—patach, sheva, patach, sheva, patach; the fifth section—sheva, patach, sheva, patach; the sixth section—kamatz, sheva, kamatz, chirik. And one should focus on pronouncing the letters with their proper emphasis, both the emphasized and the soft sounds. 60R 65R

Afterward, one recites the third verse, "And one cried to another and said," focusing on the first "Holy" as referring to the first three sefirot: Keter, Chokhmah, and Binah. With the second "Holy," focus on the second set of three sefirot: Chesed, Gevurah, and Tiferet. With the third "Holy," focus on the third set of three sefirot: Netzach, Hod, and 70R 75R

[A] Or: "on how the Seraphim conceal their innermost nature" — This alternative more clearly expresses the paradoxical kabbalistic idea that higher angels must conceal their essence to avoid overwhelming lower beings with their intensity.

[1] The text presents a complex celestial hierarchy where the angelic realms mirror the structure of the divine sefirot (emanations), creating a comprehensive cosmic system with multiple layers of correspondences.

[i] The "42-letter Name" (שם מ״ב) is one of the most powerful divine names in Kabbalah, traditionally derived from the first 42 letters of the Torah or from the prayer Ana BeKoach. It is divided into seven names of six letters each, corresponding to the seven lower sefirot and the days of the week.

[ii] These are Hebrew vowel marks (nikudot) that indicate the precise pronunciation of the divine name being contemplated. The text provides detailed instructions on the vocalization of each section of the 42-letter name, as proper pronunciation was considered essential for effective mystical practice.

ראשון אל הג׳ ספירות ראשונות כתר חכמה ובינה. ובקדוש שני יכוין אל הג׳ ספירות שניות חסד גבורה ת״ת. ובקדוש שלישי יכוין אל השלש ספירות שלישיות נצח הוד יסוד. ובמלא כל הארץ כבודו יכוין אל הספירה העשירית ואחרונה מלמעלה למטה הנקראת ארץ ומתמלאת מכולם ע״י יסוד הנקראת כל וחוזרת ומתרצית לכולם. ומי שמרגיל עצמו לומר שבח אנא בכח[i] בעת שליטת ממשלת היום בתפלתו ובעת שליטת ממשלת הלילה בשכבו על מטתו ומכוין בכל יום לשם השולט בו משמות אלו שם אחד לכל יום ובשבת שם שקו״ציות[ii] נחלק לשלשה נגד שלש שבתות שבת כלה ושבת הגדול בשחרית ושבת סתם במנחה וכמו כן בקדושה מכוין לשתף בחינת נשמתו למעלה עם קלוס שרפי הבריאה בעולם הכסא. ובחלק השני ממנה נשמתו וגם רוחו. ובחלק השלישי ממנה נשמתו ורוחו וג״כ בחינת נפשו. ודאי שכל זה תהיה הבנה לטהרו ולקדשו ויזכה להיות קרבן ריח ניחח לה׳ ומנחה טהורה ביום סלוקו לחצרות אל. והשרפים בעלי שש כנפים

Yesod. And with "the whole earth is full of His glory," focus on the tenth and final sefirah from above to below, which is called Earth, and which is filled by all the others through Yesod, which is called "all," and which returns and becomes reconciled to all of them.

One who accustoms himself to recite the praise "Ana BeKoach" during the dominion of the day in his prayer and during the domini[B]on of the night when lying on his bed, focusing each day on the name that governs that day from these names—one name for each day—and on the Sabbath, the name SHKUTZIT is divided into three parts corresponding to three Sabbaths: the Bride Sabbath and the Great Sabbath in the morning prayer, and the regular Sabbath in the afternoon prayer. Similarly, during the Kedushah prayer,[1] he should focus on uniting the aspect of his soul above with the praise of the Seraphim of Beriah in the world of the Throne. In the second part, he should focus on his soul and also his spirit. And in the third part, he should focus on his soul and his spirit, and also the aspect of his vital soul.

Surely all this will be a preparation to purify and sanctify him, and he will merit to be "a sacrifice of sweet savor unto the LORD"[2] and a pure offering on the day of his ascent to God's courts. And the Seraphim with six wings will cover him with their pinions and will bear him up on the heights of the 72-letter Name.[A] May it be God's will that we merit to live and see length of days, and may the Supernal One be praised through us and all Israel in this world

[A] Or: "during the governance of daytime... during the governance of nighttime" — This alternative more directly conveys the kabbalistic concept that different divine powers or angelic forces govern different times of the day and night cycle.

[B] Or: "will elevate him upon the high places of the 72-letter Name" — This translation more directly echoes biblical language of 'high places' (במתי) while maintaining the mystical significance of ascent through divine realms via the power of the 72-letter divine name.

[1] The Kedushah is a sanctification prayer recited during communal worship, containing the thrice-repeated word "Holy" (Kadosh) from Isaiah's vision, which is being referenced in this text as corresponding to different groups of sefirot.

[2] This biblical phrase (קרבן ריח ניחח לה׳) originally described acceptable Temple offerings. Here it is metaphorically applied to the soul's ascent after death, suggesting that a properly prepared death is itself a form of divine service comparable to Temple sacrifice.

[i] "Ana BeKoach" (אנא בכח) is a powerful prayer attributed to the 1st-century sage Rabbi Nehunya ben HaKanah. The prayer's forty-two words are arranged in seven lines of six words each, corresponding to the 42-letter divine name.

[ii] SHKUTZIT (שקו״ציות) is likely an acronym or code name for a divine name specifically associated with Sabbath prayer. The text indicates that this name is divided into three parts corresponding to different Sabbath observances.

באברתם יסוכו עליו וישאוהו
על במתי ע״ב.[iii] יהי רצון שנזכה
ונחיה ונראה לאורך ימים ומינן
עם כל ישראל יתקלס עילאה
בעה״ז ובעה״ב אכי״ר:[iv]

and in the World to Come.[B] Amen, may it be His will.

פרק ל״ז

שבח אנא בכח מועיל להעלות
הנפש מעולם העשיה והוא שם
מ״ב מקבוץ שבעה שמות כנגד
ספירות הבנין וכנגדן במעשה
בראשית עשרה מאמרות ול״ב
נתיבות שכל אות יתלבש בו כח
ורוחניות מאחד מהמאמרות או
הנתיבות ויוצא מתחלת בראשית
עד ב׳ ובהו בתמורות אלף
ביתות העולות ואינם יורדות
הכל ברזא דבינה דסלקא
לאתעטרא לעילא לעילא. ופי׳
מורי הגאון מפאנו[i] בספר העסיס
שלו כי כל שם מ״ב מקורו

Chapter 37

The prayer Ana BeKoach helps elevate the soul from the world of Asiyah (Action). It contains the 42-letter Divine Name formed from seven names corresponding to the seven sefirot of construction.[1] These also correspond to the ten utterances of creation and 5R
the 32 paths of wisdom, with each letter embodying the power and spirituality from one of these utterances or paths. This Name is derived from the beginning of Genesis until the words "void and emptiness" through permutations of alphabets that ascend but 10R
do not descend,[2] all according to the mystery of Binah that rises to be crowned above and beyond.[3]

My teacher, the Gaon of Fano, explained in his book HaAssis that every 42-letter Name originates

[A] Or: "may the Most High be glorified through us and all Israel in this world and in the World to Come" — This alternative captures the sense of 'יתקלס' as 'glorified' or 'exalted' rather than simply 'praised,' conveying the more transcendent quality of divine glorification being invoked.

[1] These refer to the seven lower divine emanations (Chesed through Malkhut) that constitute the active, world-building aspects of divinity in Kabbalah.
[2] This refers to specific methods of letter permutation in Kabbalah where the transformations follow an upward progression without returning downward, symbolizing spiritual ascent.
[3] This describes the mystical process whereby Binah (Understanding) is elevated to receive influence from higher divine sources, with 'above and beyond' (le'eila le'eila) being a technical phrase indicating transcendence beyond normal spiritual boundaries.

[i] "The heights of the 72-letter Name" refers to another powerful divine name in Kabbalah derived from three verses in Exodus (14:19-21), each containing 72 letters. This name represents divine mercy and is associated with ascent through celestial realms.
[ii] Cf. Isaiah 6:1-3 — This prophetic vision is used as a meditation for the dying because it represents direct encounter with divine glory. Just as Isaiah experienced divine revelation while still alive, the dying person is preparing for their own direct encounter with divine reality. | Cf. Ana BeKoach prayer — The prayer is referenced as a daily practice that prepares one for the ultimate transition at death. Its 42 words correspond to the 42-letter divine name mentioned in the text, creating a mystical link between daily spiritual practice and deathbed meditation. | Cf. Zohar on the Divine Throne — The text's detailed description of the celestial realms follows Zoharic cosmology, where the different worlds (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) are arranged hierarchically, with angels serving specific functions within each realm. | Cf. Ezekiel's Throne Vision — While not directly quoted, Ezekiel's vision informs the cosmology described here, particularly the reference to Ophanim (wheels) as celestial beings in the world of Asiyah. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The text's emphasis on the proper vocalization and pronunciation of divine names reflects Sefer Yetzirah's teaching that the universe was created through specific combinations of Hebrew letters and their sounds.
[iii] The author refers here to Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano (1548-1620), an important Italian kabbalist and student of Rabbi Moses Cordovero. He is often cited in Ma'avar Yabok as 'my teacher.'

מן ההוי״ה ומלוי מלואה שהם
כ״ח אותיות כמנין מנצפ״ך
במ״ק[ii] שהם בבינה. יעויין שער
האותיות בפרדס.[iii] וסלקא
לאתעטרא במלוי שם ההוי״ה
ראשון שהוא בחכמה בן עשר
אותיות וגם במקור הפשוט י׳ דוד
שהוא בכתר[i] שהם בין הכל מ״ב
כ״ח וי׳ וד׳ שהפשוט שרש לכלם
וזהו פירוש לעילא לעילא. ויש
שם מ״ב שהוא דיוקנא דמלכא
כנתבאר בתקונים והוא שם בן
ד׳ פשוט ומלא עם מלוי מלואו
שהן מ״ב אותיות וכמוהו בשם
אה״י״ה במילוי יודין או אלפין
אלא ששניהם בני מ״א אותיות
וכללות השם משלים למ״ב וכל
זה באצילות להעלות הבריאה
אליו וכן נשמת אדם שהיא מי
הבריאה תזדכך עמה ותעלה
במדרגת אצילות אלא שהראשון
שאינו להגה הוא באצילות
הנעלם להעלות פנימיות כלי
הבריאה אכתריאל י״ה ה׳
צבאות והשני משם אהי״ה הנגלה
סוד המאמרות והכנויים הנהגים
להעלות החלק החצון מכלי
הבריאה אליהם ולהיות כי
בבחינת המאמרות יבחנו הג׳
ראשונות בסוד רישא והשבעה
בסוד דרועין וגופא וירכין
לכן יש ב׳ שמות מאהי״ה המלא
ביודי״ן להעלות סוד ג׳ ראשונות
והמלא באלפין להעלות שבע

from the Tetragrammaton and its full expansion, which contains 28 letters corresponding to the number of the five final letters (MaNTzaPaKh) in their full form, which reside in Binah. This is explained in Sha'ar HaOtiot in Pardes. It rises to be crowned in the first full expansion of the Tetragrammaton[4] which is in Chokhmah with ten letters, and also in the simple source, the Yod of David which is in Keter. Together these total 42: 28 plus 10 plus 4, with the simple form being the root of them all—this is the meaning of "above and beyond."

There is also a 42-letter Name that is the image of the King, as explained in Tikkunim. It consists of the simple four-letter Name plus its full expansion and the expansion of that expansion,[1] totaling 42 letters. Similarly with the Name Ehyeh in its expansion with Yods or Alephs, except that both contain 41 letters, and the entirety of the Name completes it to 42. All this exists in Atzilut to elevate Beriah to it, and likewise the human soul, which is from the waters of Beriah, is purified with it and ascends to the level of Atzilut.

The first, which is not pronounced, exists in the hidden Atzilut to elevate the inner aspect of the vessel of Beriah—Achtariel Yah YHVH Tzeva'ot. The second derives from the revealed Name Ehyeh, the secret of the utterances and the customary appellations that elevate the external part of the vessel of Beriah to them. Since in the aspect of the utterances, the first three sefirot are examined in the mystery of the head, and the seven in the mystery of arms, body, and thighs,[2] therefore there are two Names from Ehyeh: the one filled with Yods to ele-

[1] In Kabbalah, divine names are 'expanded' by spelling out each letter in full. The first expansion of YHVH, associated with Chokhmah, uses the letter Yod to spell out each component letter.

[2] This describes the technical kabbalistic method of triple expansion, where each letter is spelled out (milui), and then those spelled-out letters are themselves spelled out (milui d'milui), creating a cascading effect.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic anthropomorphic model of the sefirot, where the first three (Keter, Chokhmah, Binah) correspond to the head, while the seven lower sefirot correspond to the rest of the divine 'body.'

[i] MaNTzaPaKh refers to the five Hebrew letters that change form when appearing at the end of words (כ,פ,צ,נ,מ). The abbreviation 'beMK' likely refers to these letters in their 'full form' (milui) when spelled out completely.

[ii] This refers to Pardes Rimmonim (Orchard of Pomegranates), the systematic kabbalistic work by Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), specifically to the section called 'Gate of Letters.'

[iii] The phrase 'Yod of David' may refer to the letter Yod in King David's name, which in Kabbalah symbolizes his connection to Keter (Crown), the highest sefirah.

אחרונות ועד״ז יהיה העלאת
לבושי הנשמה בסוד שם אהי״ה
וחלופי המלואים כי רבו יהיה
עוד כפי השתנות הבחינות מדין
לרחמים וכפי המזגתם בפחות
ויתר. ואת שם מ״ב דדיוקנא
חתים בחותמא והוא אהי״ה
אשר אהי״ה שעולים מניינם מ״ב
וזהו בבריאה להעלות אליהם
רוחו של אדם עם כללות עולם
היצירה בכל בחינותיו כל א׳
מהם משבע כנדרש למעלה וכן
אהי״ה יה״ו שהוא שם המרגלא
המפורש בר״מ פ׳ יתרו בדבור
זכור את יום השבת עולה מ״ב
ובפ׳ תרומה דף קנ״ט תמצא
מדרוש זה ובהם דברים עתיקים
כשתבין בשמות המרגלא. וגם
בשמות הבריאה יש ב׳ בחינות
להעלאת הפנימיות היצירה
בסוד השם הראשון ובשני
לבושים וכן נדין ברוחו של אדם
ולבושו. ואית ציורא דחותמא
בשעוה תחלתו אבגית״ן עד
שקוצי״ת והוא ביצירה להעלות
אליה נפשו של אדם עם כללות
העשיה שנר״ן של אדם ימשכו
אחריהם סוד כל הכלליות שבכל
עולם להיות הוא מרכז כלם
והוא המעלה אותם בכח מעשיו
המאירים כל ההויו״ת הנותנים
חיות לכל עולם ועולם כאשר בא
בדברינו למעלה ושם זה יוצא
מבראשית הנזכר. ויש מוציאים
אותו מפסוק אז ישיר משה או
מן מ״ב אותיות אחרונות שבסוף
התורה. ובזה נכיר עילוי התורה
שבסופה נחתם שם זה המעלה
רוחניותה עד בינה בסוד אותיות
ומבינה לחכמה בסוד נקודות
ומחכמה לכתר בסוד טעמים.
עוד יש בה בחינת זיני״ן בסוד
הצחצחות[i] ומשם ומעלה ברצוא

vate the mystery of the first three, and the one filled with Alephs to elevate the final seven. Similarly, the elevation of the soul's garments occurs through the mystery of the Name Ehyeh and variations of its expansions, which are many according to the changing aspects from judgment to mercy and according to their mixture in lesser or greater degree.

The 42-letter Name of the image is sealed with a seal, which is "Ehyeh Asher Ehyeh" whose numerical value equals 42. This exists in Beriah to elevate to them a person's spirit together with the entirety of the world of Yetzirah in all its aspects, each of them consisting of seven as required above. Similarly, "Ehyeh Yahu," which is the common Name explained in Ra'aya Mehemna in Parashat Yitro in the discussion of "Remember the Sabbath day," equals 42. In Parashat Terumah, page 159, you will find this exposition containing ancient matters when you understand the common Names.

Also in the Names of Beriah, there are two aspects for elevating the inner dimension of Yetzirah through the mystery of the first Name, and in the second, garments. Similarly, we judge concerning a person's spirit and its garment. There is an impression of the seal in wax beginning with ABGITATZ and ending with SHAKUTZIT, which exists in Yetzirah to elevate to it a person's soul together with the entirety of Asiyah. For the Nefesh-Ruach-Neshamah of a person draw after them the mystery of all the collective aspects in every world, as the person is the center of them all and elevates them through the power of his deeds, which illuminate all the Divine Names that give life to each world, as we have explained above. This Name is derived from the aforementioned beginning of Genesis. Some derive it from the verse "Then Moses sang" or from the final 42 letters at the end of the Torah.

In this we recognize the elevation of the Torah, that at its end is sealed this Name that elevates its spirituality to Binah through the mystery of letters, and from Binah to Chokhmah through the mystery of vowel points, and from Chokhmah to Keter through the mystery of cantillation marks. There is

[i]The author is describing the mystical significance of Torah cantillation (ta'amim) and the letter Zayin in relation to the concept of Tzachtzachot (spiritual radiances), a technical kabbalistic term for refined divine illuminations.

ושוב:[iii] [ii]

also in it the aspect of Zayin in the mystery of the Tzachtzachot (spiritual radiances), and from there upward in "running and returning."[1]

פרק ל״ח

Chapter 38

הנה שם מ״ב אותיות בכל מקום שהוא נחלק לשבע שמות[i] ובכל אחד שש אותיות כנגד שש קצוות והשביעי סוד יום שבת שבכל שש שהיא הבינה[ii] וע״י היסוד שהוא שביעי עושה כלם נכללות משבע כי הוא המושך הבינה למטה. עוד שש אותיות שם זה הם כנגד שש כנפים אשר לשבעת השרפים שאולי ירמזו לשבעה דרגין דכורסייא או לשבעה היכלות שבם היכל היראה וכו׳ כאשר הובא בתקונים ויצדק גם כן לשבעה ספירות מחסד ולמטה וכן בשבע היכלות היצירה לבנת הספיר עצם השמים וכו׳ והיכל

Behold, the 42-letter Name in every place where it appears is divided into seven names, each containing six letters corresponding to the six directions,[2] with the seventh being the mystery of the Sabbath day that is within all six, which is Binah. Through Yesod, which is the seventh, all become included within seven, for it draws Binah downward. Furthermore, the six letters of this Name correspond to the six wings of the seven Seraphim, which perhaps allude to the seven levels of the Divine Throne, or to the seven Palaces among which is the Palace of Awe, etc., as brought in the Tikkunim. This also properly corresponds to the seven Sefirot from Chesed downward, and likewise to the seven Palaces of Yetzirah—the Palace of the Sapphire Brick, the Essence of Heaven, etc.—with

[1] This fundamental kabbalistic concept describes the soul's spiritual movement—ascending to divine heights ('running') but necessarily returning to its earthly existence, maintaining a dynamic oscillation between transcendence and immanence.

[2] In Kabbalah, the 'six directions' (שש קצוות) refer to the six spatial dimensions (north, south, east, west, up, down) which correspond to the six sefirot from Chesed to Yesod, collectively called Zeir Anpin or the 'Small Face' of divinity.

[i] This phrase 'running and returning' derives from Ezekiel's vision of the heavenly creatures (Ezekiel 1:14) and became a fundamental concept in Kabbalah describing the oscillating movement of spiritual elevation and return.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The author grounds his explanation of the 42-letter divine name in Zoharic cosmology, showing how this prayer functions to elevate the soul through the spiritual worlds. | Cf. Pardes Rimmonim — The author cites Moses Cordovero's classic Kabbalistic work to explain the technical derivation of the 42-letter name, lending authority to his explanation. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author draws on Tikkunei Zohar's discussion of divine names to explain one manifestation of the 42-letter name, showing how different kabbalistic texts describe various aspects of this mystical name. | Cf. Zohar, Ra'aya Mehemna — The author cites this specific section of the Zohar to establish that the combination of divine names 'Ehyeh Yahu' equals 42 and relates to Sabbath observance, connecting the mystical name to ritual practice. | Cf. Zohar — The author provides a specific citation to the Zohar to support his exposition, indicating that readers can find additional 'ancient matters' there about the mystical names being discussed. | Cf. Ana BeKoach prayer — The author explains the mystical structure and function of this well-known kabbalistic prayer, which consists of 42 letters arranged in seven groups of six letters each, corresponding to the seven lower sefirot. | Cf. Book of Genesis — The author describes one method of deriving the 42-letter divine name from permutations of letters in the opening verses of Genesis, connecting mystical name-derivation techniques to the biblical creation account.

[iii] The 42-letter Divine Name is traditionally divided into seven groups of six letters, forming seven distinct names. The most famous version begins with the letters אבגית״ין (ABGITATZ).

[iv] This reflects the kabbalistic correspondence between the seven lower sefirot and the days of the week, with the seventh (Sabbath) corresponding to Binah (Understanding), which represents transcendence and rest.

העליון כולל כל ג׳ ראשונות
החשובות כאחד בכל מקום.
ובסוד בנפים אלו הנשמה עולה
בכל לילה למקומה ועולה עמה
גם בחינת הרוח והנפש ולא
נשאר באדם כי אם רוח החיוני
שהוא מכח הגלגלים ולכן טוב
וראוי להזכירו על מטתו[iii] כי
בכחו תתראה נשמתו ורוחו
ונפשו למעלה בסוד קדושים.
וכמו כן בשעת הפטירה אם
ישים אליו לבו רוחו ונשמתו
אליו יאסוף ויעלהו גם עלה
ויסתירהו בסתר כנפיו וידור
ברום חביון עוזו בצרור החיים
את ה׳ אלהינו[i] וישן אז ינוח לו.
אבל בעשיה שאין תחתיה עולם
אחר שיהיה ראוי להעלותו אליה
אין דורשין בה שם של מ״ב.
ונמצא מי שסדר האצילות ששה
סדרים של מ״ב. לשש קצוות
שבו להאיר מכלם למלכות
ולהעלותה אליהם תחלה הוא
פשוט. ומלא. ומלוי המלוי. כלו
ביו״דין. ואחריו על הסדר הזה
במלוי יודי״ן חוץ מן הוא״ו שהוא
באל״ף. וכמוהו במלוי אלפין
וכן בהי״ן אלא שזה האחרון
כלו לג׳ אותיות לבד. וצריך
להוסיף בו ט׳ ווי״ן של ברכת
כהנים והם ט׳ ווי״ן אשר בפסוק
והבל הביא גם הוא.[ii] שבן יסוד
ששה זה כנגדו הבל יוצא מפי
האמה וממשיך ברכת החסד כהן
עליון הכולל כל שאר הכתרים
שתחתיו למלכות וביברכך עושה

the highest Palace encompassing all three supreme Sefirot, which are considered as one in every place.

Through the mystery of these wings, the soul ascends each night to its place, and with it also rise the aspects of Ruach and Nefesh, leaving in the person only the vital spirit which derives from the power of the celestial spheres. Therefore it is good and proper to invoke this Name upon one's bed, for through its power, one's Neshamah, Ruach, and Nefesh will appear above among the holy ones. Similarly, at the time of death, if one focuses their heart upon it, "He will gather his spirit and soul to Himself," raising them up and concealing them in the shelter of His wings, to dwell in the height of His hidden strength, in the bond of life with the Lord our God—and then when one sleeps, one will find rest. However, regarding the world of Asiyah, below which there is no other world worthy of being elevated to it, the 42-letter Name is not expounded. 20R 25R 30R 35R

One who arranges the six orders of the 42-letter Name in Atzilut for its six directions, to illuminate from all of them to Malkhut and elevate it to them, begins with the simple form, then the filled form, and then the filling of the filling[1]—all with Yuds. Following this comes the same order with Yuds in the filling, except for the Vav which is with Alef. Similarly with the filling of Alefs, and likewise with Heis, except that this last one is only for three letters. One must add to it the nine Vavs of the Priestly Blessing, which are the nine Vavs in the verse "And Abel also brought." For Yesod, which is sixth, corresponds to the breath that issues from the mouth of the amah[2] (channel), drawing down the blessing of Chesed—the High Priest who includes all the other crowns beneath him—to Malkhut. With "may He bless you," a line is drawn from the right; with "may 40R 45R 50R

[1]This refers to the kabbalistic practice of 'filling' divine names by spelling out each letter's name. For example, the letter Yod (י) spelled out is יוד, and 'filling of the filling' would spell out each letter in that spelled-out form, creating increasingly complex expansions of the original name.

[2]The term 'amah' (אמה) here has multiple layers of meaning, referring both to a channel through which divine influence flows and, in its esoteric sense, to the divine phallus or procreative power that channels spiritual energy to lower realms.

[i]This refers to the kabbalistic practice of reciting the 42-letter Divine Name before sleep as a protective measure and to facilitate the soul's ascent during sleep.

[ii]The phrase 'bound in the bond of life' (צרור החיים) comes from 1 Samuel 25:29 and became a common expression on Jewish tombstones, expressing the hope that the deceased's soul is preserved in eternal life with God.

[iii]This refers to Genesis 4:4, about Abel's offering. The author is noting that this verse contains nine instances of the letter Vav, which have mystical significance in relation to the Priestly Blessing.

ה קו מן ימין. וביאר קו שמאל.
ובישא קו האמצעי. ועוד יוצא
55 משם שם של כ״ב נגד כ״ב אותיות
שהיא כלולה מת״ת מאל״ף עד
ת״ו ועוד נכלל בג׳ הוי״ת
שבו שם י״ב הרומז יחוד הגמור
ולכן טוב לכוין בו בסוף כל
60 ברכה לברך בו עמו ישראל
הנכללים במלכות בשלום רב
וממנו יוצאים ע״ב צרופי הוי״ת
בני ד׳ אותיות כי נצרף שם
בן ד׳ לכ״ד צרופים וכן לכל
65 אחד מג׳ שמות הנזכרים והם
מתלבשות בע״ב שמות היוצאים
מן ויסע ויבא ויט: ואמרו בזהר
פרשת תרומה דף רל״ד כי אורים
ותומים היו שם מ״ב וע״ב ולבושי
70 כהן גדול היו בגוונא דלבושי
מיכאל ופירש בדף רכ״ט למה
נקראים בגדי שרד ובאורים
ותומים היה סוד אספקלריאה
המאירה ושאינה מאירה ובסוד
75 זה בשהיה מברך הכהן העם היה
מעורר הברכה מרחובות הנהר
כי בברכת כהנים אית בה תשעה
תקוני זעיר בסוד י״הו הבונות
תשעה בתים ונמתקים מעתיקא
80 קדישא ששם י״ג תקוני דיקנא
יקירא עילאה ואח״כ נשפעים
ממותקים למלכות ע״י יסוד
וזהו שים שלום טובה וברכה
שבסוף התפלה שהוא היחוד
85 הגמור וכל זה באור פניך שהוא
הארת הפנים העליונים בסוד שם
הוי״ה מלא ביודי״ן בגימטרי״א
ע״ב הנותן נשמה לכל ע״י אור
הכתר הנשפע בחכמה שמחיה
90 את בעליה הרי אלו ד׳ שמות
של מ״ב לגג״ת ויסוד ושם חמישי
לנצח הוא עם מלוי שם הוי״ה

He illuminate you," a line from the left; and with "may He lift up," the middle line.

From there emerges a 22-letter Name corresponding to the 22 letters which are included in Tiferet, from Alef to Tav. Additionally, the three Tetragrammatons within it comprise a 12-letter Name alluding to complete unification. Therefore it is good to have in mind at the end of every blessing to bless with it His people Israel, who are included in Malkhut, with abundant peace. From it emerge 72 permutations of the four-letter Tetragrammaton,[3] for we permute the four-letter Name into 24 combinations, and likewise for each of the three Names mentioned, and these become clothed in the 72 Names derived from "And he journeyed," "And he came," and "And he stretched out" [Exodus 14:19-21].

They said in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 234, that the Urim and Thummim were the 42-letter and 72-letter Names, and the garments of the High Priest were like the garments of Michael. It explains on page 229 why they are called "service garments," and in the Urim and Thummim was the mystery of the luminous speculum and the non-luminous speculum.[1] Through this mystery, when the priest blessed the people, he would awaken the blessing from the broadways of the River, for in the Priestly Blessing there are nine arrangements of Zeir Anpin based on the letters Yod-Hei-Vav,[2] which build nine houses, and they are sweetened from the Holy Ancient One, where there are thirteen arrangements of the precious supernal beard. Afterwards, they flow sweetened to Malkhut through Yesod. This is the meaning of "Establish peace, goodness, and blessing" at the end of the prayer, which is the complete unification. All this is "in the light of Your countenance," which is the illumination of the supernal countenance, through the mystery of the Tetragrammaton fully spelled with Yuds, numerically equivalent to 72, which gives the soul to all through the light of Keter flowing into Chokhmah, bringing life to its possessor.

[1] In Kabbalah, the divine name YHVH can be written in 24 different permutations. When each of the three divine names mentioned is permuted in 24 ways, the total becomes 72, corresponding to the 72-letter divine name derived from Exodus 14:19-21.

[2] These terms ('אספקלריאה המאירה' and 'אספקלריאה שאינה מאירה') refer to different levels of prophetic vision. Moses is said to have prophesied through the luminous speculum (clear glass), while other prophets saw through the non-luminous speculum (clouded glass).

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the three letters of YHV, when each is placed in first, second, or third position, create nine combinations that correspond to specific divine channels through which blessing flows.

ביודי״ן קס״א מלוי שם אהי״ה
ביודי״ן מ״ה מלוי שם הוי״ה
באלפין תרע״א מלוי שם א״ד
שהם מ״ב אותיות. ששי להוד
והוא שם ס״ג מלוי הוי״ה בג׳
יודי״ן ואל״ף בוא״ו קמ״ג שם
אהי״ה באלפין מ״ה תרע״א
וצרוף קמ״ג עם ס״ג ניחא משום
אל״ף שבשם ס״ג שהיא שרש לכל
האלפין שבשם מ״ה וקמ״ג. ועוד
כי קס״א הוא חסד בערך הוד
שהוא דין ושם מ״ב של אהי״ה
פשוט ומלא מלוי מלואו יפורש
אם ביודי״ן במלכות בהשואתה
למעלה ואם באלפין בהשואתה
למטה וכללות השם משלים
בשניהם ואם בההין שאותיותיו
ט״ל בלבד יצדק בבריאה וג׳
שמות אהי״ה שבתורה ישלימו.
עוד ב׳ אהי״ה במספרם עולים
מ״ב וכן אהיה שלישי מצטרף עם
יה״ו גם הם מ״ב. וסוד זה השם
הנורא של מ״ב מבואר בזהר
ובתקונים בכמה מקומות ובפרט
בתקון רביעי ושם בדף ק״ב ע״א
כתב שממנו נעשה ז׳ היכלות
כנזכר למעלה. ובדף קל״ד
מבאר באורך סודו ונקודותיו
ומוצאו ושמות היוצאים ממנו
והם כתובים בספ״ר יע״ש.
ויוצא ממדת הגבורה והן בחות
שכליות אלהיות וכבודו של
מקום מתאחד בהם ומתעלה
עד אין סוף לרוממותו כאשר
כתבנו למעלה. כמו שאמרו
באלפא ביתא של ר׳ עקיבא
על ע״ב שמות המסודרים על
סדר האל״ף בית שהם יוצאים
מלפני כסא הכבוד בכתרים של
אש ולהבה.[i] כי הם עצם אמיתי
ואותיות פורחות למעלה בעקר
המרכבה והם ממונים לעשות
כל דבר מהם. וכבר כתבנו כי
שם מ״ב מעלה את הנשמה ע״י
השרפים בעלי שש כנפים. ושמות
המרגלא אהי״ה יה״ו מעלה

These, then, are four forms of the 42-letter Name for Chesed-Gevurah-Tiferet and Yesod. The fifth form, for Netzach, consists of the filled Tetragrammaton with Yuds (161), the filled Name Ehyeh with Yuds (45), the filled Tetragrammaton with Alefs (671), and the filled Name AD, totaling 42 letters. The sixth, for Hod, consists of the Name SaG (63)—the Tetragrammaton filled with three Yuds and Alef in the Vav—plus the Name KaMaG (143), plus the Name Ehyeh filled with Alefs (45), equaling 671. The combination of 143 with 63 works well because of the Alef in the Name SaG, which is the root of all the Alefs in the Names MaH and KaMaG. Furthermore, 161 is Chesed in relation to Hod, which is Din (judgment). 95R 100R 105R

The 42-letter Name derived from Ehyeh—simple, filled, and filling of the filling—can be interpreted with Yuds in Malkhut when it is equated with the higher realms, or with Alefs when it is equated with the lower realms, with the entirety of the Name completing both interpretations. If with Heis, whose letters total only 39, it is properly associated with Beriah, and the three Ehyeh Names in the Torah complete it. Additionally, two Ehyeh Names in their numerical value equal 42, and likewise the third Ehyeh combined with YHV also equals 42. 110R 115R

The mystery of this awesome 42-letter Name is explained in the Zohar and Tikkunim in many places, particularly in the fourth Tikkun, where on page 102a it states that from it are formed the seven Palaces mentioned above. On page 134, it explains at length its mystery, its vowel points, its origin, and the names derived from it, which are written in the book—see there. It emerges from the attribute of Gevurah, and these are divine intellectual powers with which the glory of the Omnipresent unites and elevates itself infinitely in His exaltedness, as we wrote above. As they said in the Alpha-Beta of Rabbi Akiva concerning the 72 Names arranged according to the alphabet, that they issue from before the Throne of Glory with crowns of fire and flame, for they are true essence, and the letters fly upward in the foundation of the Divine Chariot, and they are appointed to accomplish everything through them. 120R 125R 130R 135R

We have already written that the 42-letter Name

[i] This describes the divine names as emanating directly from the Throne of Glory adorned with fiery crowns, emphasizing their exalted spiritual origin and power.

הרוח מעולם היצירה בכוין בהם. ובפ׳ תרומה מתבאר שם מ״ב וע״ב.[ii] ומדרגת כל אחד מהם. ואותיות הוי״ה והמלוי ומלוי המלוי שהם ג״פ מ״ב מועיל המחשבה בהם להעלות הנשמה מעולם הבריאה כנתבאר בפרטות למעלה בזה:[i]

elevates the Neshamah through the Seraphim with six wings, while the commonly known Names Ehyeh and YHV elevate the Ruach from the world of Yetzirah when one focuses on them. In Parashat Terumah, the 42-letter and 72-letter Names are explained, along with the level of each. Meditation on the letters of the Tetragrammaton, its filling, and the filling of its filling[1]—which are three times 42—helps elevate the Neshamah from the world of Beriah, as explained in detail above.

פרק ל״ט

Chapter 39

בין תבין בר״מ פרשת צו[ii] ומשם יתגלה לך יחוד שמע ישראל וברוך שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד בשעת מיתה. וכוונת הודוי שהוא לקרבא שם אדנ״י דאכיל ושצי בדינוהי לגבי יה״ו אהיה העולים מ״ב כנזכר.[iii] ויכוין ג״כ בשם מ״ה בלב אחד ובנפש דיליה מקבל עליו מיתה ויסורין. ובנשמתא מודה בכמה ודויי

You will understand from the Ra'aya Mehemna in Parashat Tzav, which will reveal to you the unification of "Shema Yisrael" and "Baruch Shem Kevod Malchuto Le'olam Va'ed"[2] at the time of death. And the intention of confession is to bring near the name ADNY, which consumes and destroys in its judgments, to YHV EHYEH,[3] which together equal 42 as mentioned. One should also focus on the name MA"H (45) with a single heart, and with one's soul accept death and suffering. With the neshamah, one

[1]The author describes an advanced kabbalistic meditation practice wherein one contemplates increasingly complex expansions of divine names to elevate the soul through higher spiritual worlds, with each level of expansion corresponding to a different spiritual realm.

[2]These are the first line of the central Jewish prayer affirming God's unity ("Hear O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is One") and the response traditionally recited in an undertone ("Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever"). The text explains their mystical significance when recited at death.

[3]The text describes a mystical process of unifying divine names representing judgment (ADNY) with those representing mercy (YHV EHYEH), suggesting that proper confession transforms harsh judgment into compassion.

[i]The author refers to the Zohar portion of Terumah which elaborates on both the 42-letter and 72-letter Divine Names and their respective spiritual functions.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Terumah — The author uses this Zohar reference to establish the relationship between the 42-letter Name, the priestly garments, and the mystical mechanisms through which blessings flow through various levels of divinity | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author draws on these kabbalistic sources to legitimize and deepen his explanation of the 42-letter Name's mystical structure and function in spiritual elevation | Cf. Alpha-Beta of Rabbi Akiva — The author uses this reference to establish the profound divine nature of these sacred names and their direct connection to the highest spiritual realms | Cf. Exodus 14:19-21 — The author mentions this standard kabbalistic derivation to show how the 72 permutations of the Divine Name emerge from biblical text, thus rooting mystical practice in scripture | Cf. Priestly Blessing — The author analyzes the nine Vavs in this blessing as channels for divine energy from higher spiritual realms to lower ones, demonstrating how ritual action creates cosmic effects

[iii]The text begins by referring to Ra'aya Mehemna ('The Faithful Shepherd'), a section of the Zohar attributed to Moses, specifically the portion on Parashat Tzav. This serves as an authoritative source for the mystical practices described.

[iv]The text specifies that the combined numerical value of the divine names YHV and EHYEH equals 42, which is significant in Jewish mysticism as the 42-letter divine name (Shem Mem-Bet) that has special power for soul elevation.

ומתחרט בנפש מקבל עליו
מאהבה ארבע מיתות ב״ד[iv] אם
צריך להם לכפרת נפשו ולתקן
פגם שעשה בארבע אותיות
משלש שמות הכוללים הכל
שהם הוי״ה אהי״ה אדנו״ת.
וכשנשמתיה מודה בכמה ודויין.
ותב בתיובתא לגבי אהי״ה
דאחיד בתרין שמהן ה׳ ה׳
שהם אריך וזעיר הראשון זעיר
המתיחד וקורא לארוך שבו שם
קדוש שהוא שם הוי״ה ואהי״ה
משולבים שהם בחינת רישא. וזה
סוד הפרק שבין שם לשם יורה
לסוד הדעת המזווגם[i] במחשבתיה
יכיל לאפקא עליה ודוי וקבלת
מיתה בלב אחד דהוא שם מ״ה
דביה היו כורעים ומשתחוים
ואומרים ברוך שם כבוד מלכותו
לעולם ועד כבוד הוא ל״ב.[ii] בו
היה מכוין לגמור את השם ואומר
הוא אחד בלב. ויחוד שמע
ובשכמל״ו הוא לקרבא נשמתיה
מאנא לשם ה׳. ועם הארץ
דלא ידע דא והוא בבעידא
דכיא[iii] שור או שה או עז או תור
או בן יונה מיכאל דהוא כהנא
רבא[iv] אריה דאכיל קורבנייא

confesses with many confessions, and with contrition of soul, one accepts with love the four court-imposed death penalties[4] if needed for the atonement of one's soul and to rectify the blemish made in the four letters of the three names that encompass all, which are YHVH, EHYEH, and ADNUT. 15R

When one's soul confesses with many confessions and returns in repentance to EHYEH, which holds the two names H' H' representing Arich and Zeir[1]—the first being Zeir which unifies and calls to the Arich within it, which is the holy name formed by the interwoven names YHVH and EHYEH that are the aspect of the Head. This is the secret of the joint between name and name, pointing to the secret of Da'at that blends them. In one's thought, one can bring forth confession and acceptance of death with a single heart, which is the name MA"H (45), through which they would bow and prostrate and say, "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever"—where "glory" equals 32.[2] With this, one would intend to complete the Name and say "He is One" in the heart. The unification of Shema and "Blessed be the name..." is to bring one's soul as a vessel to the name of God. 20R 25R 30R

As for the unlearned person who does not know this, who is like a pure animal—an ox, sheep, goat, bull, or young dove[3]—Michael, who is the High Priest, a lion who consumes offerings, descends upon 35R

[1]This refers to stoning, burning, beheading, and strangling—the four forms of capital punishment in ancient Jewish law. The text suggests that accepting these spiritually at death provides atonement.

[2]These are kabbalistic terms referring to divine configurations: Arich Anpin (Long-Faced One) represents a higher level of divine mercy, while Zeir Anpin (Small-Faced One) represents the divine configuration that more directly interacts with creation.

[3]The Hebrew word 'kavod' (glory) has a numerical value of 32, which corresponds to the 32 paths of wisdom in Kabbalistic tradition.

[4]These are animals that were considered appropriate for Temple sacrifices in biblical law. The metaphor suggests that even an unlearned person becomes a pure offering through proper death.

[i]The four court-imposed death penalties in Jewish law were stoning, burning, beheading, and strangling. The text suggests that accepting these spiritually at death (through proper confession) provides atonement for sins.

[ii]The concept of Da'at (Knowledge) in Kabbalah represents the point where divine masculine and feminine attributes blend together. It serves as the connecting point between the higher sefirot (Keter, Chokhmah, Binah) and the lower sefirot.

[iii]The Hebrew word for 'glory' (kavod) has a numerical value of 32, which corresponds to the 32 paths of wisdom in Kabbalistic tradition, connecting this prayer to divine wisdom.

[iv]The text compares the unlearned person to a pure animal suitable for sacrifice, using sacrificial animals mentioned in the Torah. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that different souls require different paths of elevation.

[v]Michael is portrayed as the celestial High Priest who offers souls as sacrifices before God, continuing the Temple service in the spiritual realms after the earthly Temple's destruction.

נחית עליה כד תב במיתתיה
40 והוא עביד ליה עולה וקרבנא קדם ה׳. והוא מכוין בשמא מפרש שהוא שם הוי״ה במלוי מ״ה בגימטרי״א אד״ם[v] בסליקו דרוחיה. ובכל יומא אצטריך בר
45 נש לאהדרא בתיובתא ולממסר רוחיה לגביה ויפיק באחד. הדא הוא דכתיב בידך אפקיד רוחי. הי לך יחוד שעושה הצדיק בנשמתו בעת פטירתה ולזה
50 יכוונו העומדים עליו וגם הוא אם ראה אור בחייו. נעתק מספר הזהר פרשת ויחי דף רל״ה ע״א ועיין עוד מזה בדף רמ״ה ושם אמר דאית תלת נשמתין בעולם
55 ונשמת הצדיקים היא השלישית מהם דרוש נאה. רבי אליעזר שאיל שאלתא לר״ש אמר הואיל וקודשא בריך הוא גלי קמיה דבני נשא ימותון אמאי נחית
60 נשמתין לעלמא ואמא. אצטריך ליה, א״ל שאלתא דא קמי דרבנן שאילו במה ובמה ואוקמוה. אבל קוב״ה יהיב נשמתין דנחתין להאי עלמא לאשתמודעא יקריה
65 ונקיט לון לבתר. אי הכי אמאי נחתי אלא רזא דא הכי הוא. פתח ואמר שתה מים מבורך ונוזלים מתוך בארך והא אוקימנא בור אתר דלא נביע מגרמיה.[i] ואימתי
70 נבעין הני מיא בשעתא דאשתלים נשמתא בהאי עלמא כד סלקא להההוא אתר דאתקשר ביה כדין הוא שלים מתתא ומעילא מכל

him when he repents at his death, and makes him an elevation offering before God. He focuses on the explicit name, which is the name YHVH spelled out to equal 45 in gematria,[4] equivalent to ADA"M, as his spirit ascends. Every day, a person needs to return in repentance and entrust his spirit to Him and depart with "Echad" (One). This is what is written: "Into Your hand I commit my spirit." This is the unification that the righteous one performs with his soul at the time of its departure, and this is what those standing around him should intend, as well as himself if he has seen the light in his lifetime.

This is copied from the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, page 235a. See more on this on page 245, where it states that there are three types of souls in the world, and the souls of the righteous are the third among them—a beautiful exposition. Rabbi Eliezer asked Rabbi Shimon: "Since the Holy One, blessed be He, knows that humans will die, why does He send souls into the world at all? What need has He for this?" He replied: "This question has been asked many times before the Rabbis, and they established [an answer]. But the Holy One, blessed be He, gives souls that descend to this world to make His glory known, and afterward takes them back. If so, why do they descend? The secret is as follows." He opened and said: "Drink water from your cistern, and flowing waters from your well." We have established that a cistern is a place that does not spring forth by itself.[1] When do these waters spring forth? At the time when the soul is completed in this world, when it ascends to that place to which it is bound, then it is complete from below and from above, from all sides. And when the soul ascends, then the desire of the female is aroused toward the male.[2] Then waters

[1] This refers to spelling out each letter of the divine name: Yod (יוד), Heh (הא), Vav (ואו), Heh (הא), which totals 45 in gematria (Hebrew numerology).

[2] This mystical interpretation distinguishes between a passive receptacle (cistern) and an active wellspring, using it as a metaphor for how the soul's completion transforms spiritual receptivity into active flow.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of divine masculine and feminine principles (often represented by the sefirot of Tiferet and Malkhut) whose unification creates cosmic harmony and divine flow.

[i] When the divine name YHVH is spelled out in a specific way (yod-heh-vav-heh), its numerical value equals 45 (MA'H), which also equals the numerical value of ADAM (man). This creates a mystical connection between the divine name and human essence.

[ii] The Zohar distinguishes between a 'cistern' (בור/bor) which does not generate its own water and must be filled, and a 'well' (באר/be'er) which has a spring. This is a metaphor for different spiritual states of receptivity versus active flow.

סטרין. וכד נשמתא סלקא כדין
איתער תיאובתא דנוקבא לגבי
דכורא. וכדין נבעין מיא מתתא
לעילא ובור אתעביד באר מיין
נביעין וכדין אתחברותא ויסודא
ותיאובתא ורעוא ויחודא אשתכח
דהא צדיקא אשלים ההוא אתר.
ואתער חביבותא וריעותא
לעילא ואתחבר בחד.[i] עוד
ראוי לדעת כוונת ירידת
הנשמות בעה״ז הוא להיותם
בעבודתם כיתדות האוחזות הכח
העליון[ii] המתלבש בספירות
להיותו מתלבש מדה במדה
להנהיג. כאלו יצוייר שאין
נשמות בעולם הרוח הקדוש היה
מסתלק והיינו רוחו ונשמתו אליו
יאסוף יגוע כל בשר יחד.[iii] ולזה
כיון שהנשמות מתלבשות בגופות
אוחזות באותו רוח שיתלבש.
בספירות העליונות ותכלית
זה יושלם יותר בתחיה כי
יזדככו הגופות ויתוקנו הנשמות
ויתקשרו הצדיקים ויעמדו על
משמרתם ותקונם ויפיים כל
אחד בקומה שלמה מכוון במדתו
ובמרכבתו[iv] ותהיה קומה
העליונה מכוונת נגד התחתונה
והתחתונה נגד העליונה. ותקון
זה היה ראוי להיות מתחלת
הבריאה אלא שגרם החטא
להיות העולם תחת הנהגת

spring from below upward, and the cistern becomes a well of flowing waters. Then connection, foundation, desire, will, and unification are found, for the righteous one has completed that place and aroused love and friendship above, and all becomes united as one. 75R

Furthermore, it is important to know that the purpose of souls descending into this world is that through their service, they act as stakes that hold the supernal power[1] that clothes itself in the sefirot, enabling it to clothe itself measure by measure to govern. If one could imagine that there were no souls in the world, the Holy Spirit would depart, and "He would gather to Himself His spirit and His breath; all flesh would perish together." Therefore, since souls clothe themselves in bodies, they grasp that spirit so that it may clothe itself in the supernal sefirot. This purpose will be fulfilled more completely in the resurrection,[2] for then bodies will be purified, souls will be rectified, the righteous will be bound together and stand at their posts and in their rectification, each one mediating with complete stature, aligned with his attribute and his chariot. The supernal structure will be aligned with the lower one, and the lower with the supernal. 80R 85R 90R 95R

This rectification should have been in place from the beginning of creation, but sin caused the world to fall under the governance of the sabbatical of judgment,[3] for they would journey first in their governance. In this, there is no wonder why, as it were, the Creator of the world had no satisfaction in His world from the day of creation until the world will 100R 105R

[1] The text presents a cosmic purpose for human souls: they serve as anchoring points for divine energy in the physical world, suggesting that human existence is necessary for the maintenance of creation itself.

[2] The Jewish belief in bodily resurrection (techiyat ha-metim) is presented here as the ultimate fulfillment of creation's purpose, when the physical and spiritual realms will be perfectly aligned.

[3] This refers to a cosmic cycle dominated by divine severity rather than mercy. In kabbalistic thought, different cosmic cycles emphasize different divine attributes.

[i] The phrase 'becoming united as one' refers to the mystical unification (yichud) of divine masculine and feminine principles, a central concept in Kabbalah that is considered the ultimate cosmic purpose.

[ii] The metaphor of souls as 'stakes' or 'pegs' holding divine power suggests that human souls serve as anchoring points for divine energy in the physical world, giving them cosmic significance beyond individual salvation.

[iii] This is an allusion to Job 34:14-15, which describes God's absolute power over life. The text uses this verse to emphasize the dependence of physical existence on divine spiritual sustenance.

[iv] The phrase 'complete stature' (komah shelemah) refers to the kabbalistic concept of Adam Kadmon (Primordial Man), the complete divine anthropomorphic structure that perfectly embodies all divine attributes.

שמיטת הדין[v] כי ראשונה יסעו בהנהגתם. ובזה אין לתמוה למה כביכו״ל לא היה לבורא עולם נחת רוח בעולמו מיום הבריאה
110 עד כי יתוקן העולם על דרך ורעם גבורותיו מי יתבונן[i] ולא היה לנשמות להתאסף לעה״ב מעט מעט ח״ו. וזהו בדמות אלהים עשה אותו וכל תקון
115 האבות והדורות יהיה באלו גלגל להנהגה נוהגת כל שיתא אלפי שני עלמא בתקונהא הראשון על כן הוצרכו היסורים והמיתה והגליות משמטת הגבורה
120 הלזו לתקן המעוות שהוא כמשל רוכב הסוס[ii] שעסקיו רעים ואינו הולך בדרך ישרה והרוכב מנהגו כפי עקשותו אך לסוף יגיע אחר הטרדא אל מקום שהיה חפצו
125 לילך מתחלה כך עצת ה׳ לעולם תעמוד בתקון העולם בכלל ובפרט:[iii]

be rectified, as it says: "Who can understand the thunder of His mighty deeds?"[4] And souls would not have needed to gather to the World to Come little by little, God forbid. This is the meaning of "in the image of God He made him," and all the 110R
rectification of the patriarchs and generations will be as if turning the wheel back to the governance that should have prevailed throughout the six thousand years of the world in its original rectification. Therefore, sufferings, death, and exiles were neces- 115R
sary from this sabbatical of Gevurah to rectify what was distorted. This is like the parable of one riding a horse[1] whose actions are evil and does not go on the straight path; the rider manages it according to its stubbornness, but in the end, after the trouble, 120R
he will reach the place he originally wanted to go. Similarly, "the counsel of the Lord stands forever," in the rectification of the world in general and in particular.

פרק מ׳

Chapter 40

[1] This is a reference to Job 26:14, suggesting that divine power and cosmic processes are ultimately beyond human comprehension.
[2] This parable illustrates divine providence working through indirect means, allowing for apparent detours while still ultimately reaching the desired destination.

[i] The 'sabbatical of judgment' refers to a cosmic cycle dominated by divine severity rather than mercy. In kabbalistic thought, different cosmic cycles emphasize different divine attributes.
[ii] This is a reference to Job 26:14, suggesting that divine power and cosmic processes are ultimately beyond human comprehension, even while the text attempts to explain them.
[iii] The parable of the rider and the stubborn horse illustrates how divine providence works through indirect means, allowing for apparent detours while still ultimately reaching the desired destination.
[iv] Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna in Parashat Tzav — The author cites this text as an authoritative source for the mystical intentions required when reciting the Shema prayer at the moment of death, establishing the importance of proper ritual practices with the correct spiritual focus. | Cf. Zohar Parashat Vayechi — The author quotes this passage to explain the cosmic purpose of souls entering the physical world and how their eventual return creates a unification and flowing of divine energy in the upper realms, supporting the book's understanding of death as a completion rather than merely an ending. | Cf. Proverbs 5:15 — The author uses this verse, through its Zoharic interpretation, to explain how the soul's completion of its earthly mission transforms the divine feminine (represented by the cistern/well) from a receptive state to an active flowing state, creating cosmic unification. | Cf. Shema Yisrael — The author explains the mystical significance of reciting these prayers at the time of death, revealing how they create divine unifications in the upper worlds when recited with proper intention (kavvanah), particularly by the righteous. | Cf. Job 34:14-15 — The author uses this verse to explain the cosmic significance of human souls, suggesting that they serve as anchoring points for divine energy in the physical world, without which creation could not be sustained.

מורה מקום מהזוהר ותקונים[iv] מהרבה דרושים השייכים לכוונת הספר הלז[i] [ii]

Index of References[2] from the Zohar and Tikkunim Pertaining to the Purpose of This Book

עיין בזהר פר׳ ויקהל מדף ר״י עד דף רי״ב משם תראה הממונים על הנשמה ואומרים לה יבא שלום[iii] וי״ב זיני דבוסמין[iv] המכינים לבושים שבתוכם נרשמים כל מעשים טובים שעשתה בעה״ז ורקיע ג״ע הנוטף טל תורה על נשמות לטהרם. ועמוד שבאמצע הרקיע שבו פורחין הנשמות לג״ע עליון. ולבושים שהם מרעותא וכונה. ושרש נהר היוצא מעדן ואפי׳ בג״ע תחתון. ופי׳ ג״ע. ומה הם צחצחות.[v] וענן. ועשן. ונגה. המקפים על הנשמות העולים דרך העמוד. ופי׳ מכון הר ציון וענג נשמות העולות.

See the Zohar, Parshat Vayakhel from page 210 to page 212, where you will find the appointed guardians over the soul who say to it, "May peace come," and the twelve types of fragrances[1] that prepare garments in which all the good deeds performed in this world are recorded. There is also the firmament of the Garden of Eden that drips the dew of Torah upon souls to purify them, and the pillar in the center of the firmament through which souls ascend to the supernal Garden of Eden. You will learn about garments formed from desire and intention,[2] the source of the river flowing from Eden even in the lower Garden of Eden, and the explanation of the Garden of Eden itself.

You will discover what are the "tzachtzachot" (radiant lights),[3] and the cloud, smoke, and brightness that surround the souls ascending through the pillar.

[1] This section marks the beginning of a comprehensive reference guide to Zoharic and other kabbalistic sources that form the textual foundation for Ma'avar Yabok's teachings on death and the afterlife. Such indices were important in scholarly works to demonstrate the author's textual authority and to help readers trace concepts to their original sources.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, these fragrances (bosmin) are not physical scents but spiritual essences that form the soul's garments in the afterlife, composed of the good deeds performed during life.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that spiritual intentions (kavvanot) and proper desires (re'uta) create ethereal garments for the soul in the afterlife, distinct from those formed by actual deeds.

[4] I've transliterated this term while providing its meaning in parentheses because it's a technical kabbalistic term referring to particularly refined spiritual illuminations experienced by the soul in the highest realms.

[i] The term 'moreh makom' (literally 'showing the place') refers to an index or reference guide. The author is introducing a directory of relevant passages from the Zohar and Tikkunim (Tikkunei Zohar) that support the book's teachings.

[ii] The phrase 'kavannat ha-sefer halaz' refers to the purpose or intention of this book, Ma'avar Yabok. This index will point readers to the mystical sources that underpin the book's approach to death, burial rituals, and the soul's journey.

[iii] Cf. Zohar — The author is creating a reference guide to Zoharic passages relevant to death, mourning, and the afterlife to establish the textual basis for Ma'avar Yabok's teachings and show its grounding in authoritative kabbalistic literature. | Cf. Tikkunim — The author includes references to Tikkunei Zohar alongside the main Zohar text to provide comprehensive sources for the kabbalistic concepts discussed in Ma'avar Yabok, particularly those related to the soul's journey after death.

[iv] This refers to angelic beings who greet and guide the soul as it enters the afterlife. According to the Zohar, these appointed guardians welcome righteous souls with the greeting "May peace come."

[v] The "twelve types of fragrances" have mystical significance in Kabbalah, corresponding to the twelve tribes of Israel and various spiritual configurations. These fragrances are spiritual essences that form the soul's garments in the afterlife.

[vi] This term derives from Isaiah 58:11 ("וְהִשְׂבִּיעַ בְּצַחֲצָחוֹת נַפְשֶׁךָ") and in Kabbalah refers to the highest spiritual radiances or illuminations that souls experience in the afterlife.

וסוד רחיצת הנשמות בנהר דינור.[vi] וב׳ מיני צרופים לנשמות ולמה נקרא גיהנם. עוד מעבירין אותה באש כשמעלין אותה לג״ע עליון. וכמה דרושים בשכר הנשמות. ועוד נדבר מזה לפנים בס״ד. ועיין בפ׳ פקודי יחוד שעושים הנשמות [i]

There is an explanation of "the foundation of Mount Zion" and the delight of ascending souls, as well as the secret of souls being washed in the River of Fire. You will learn about the two types of purifications for souls and why it is called Gehenna. Furthermore, souls are passed through fire when they are elevated to the supernal Garden of Eden. There are many discourses on the reward of souls, and we will speak more of this further on, God willing.[1]

Examine also Parshat Pekudei regarding the unification performed by souls.

העולות בכל לילה בבטן האם העליונה[ii] בקשוטי מצוותיהם.[iii] וזה על פסוק חדשים לבקרים. וגם זה נדרש בפ׳ נח דף ס׳ ע״ב ובפ׳ ויחי דף רמ״ד ע״ב ומ״ה. ושם צריך חלוקא דרבנן[iv] לנשמות בדף ס״ו ע״ב. ועליית הנשמה למזבח העליון הובא בסתרי תורה דף פ׳. ושם דרוש על ד׳ מדרגות

[This passage] ascend each night into the womb of the Supernal Mother,[2] adorned with their commandments.[3] This is explained regarding the verse "new every morning"[4] [Lamentations 3:23]. This matter is also expounded in Parashat Noach, page 60b, and in Parashat Vayechi, pages 244b and 45. There it is stated that souls need the "scholarly garment"[5] as explained on page 66b. The ascent of the soul to the supernal altar is discussed in Sitrei Torah (Secrets of Torah) on page 80, where there is also a discourse on

[1]The phrase "בס״ד" (be-siyata di-shmaya) is an Aramaic expression meaning "with the help of Heaven," which I've rendered as "God willing" to maintain the author's reverent tone while expressing his intention to elaborate on these topics later in the book.

[2]This refers to the kabbalistic belief that during sleep, souls partially detach from the body and ascend to higher spiritual realms for renewal and instruction.

[3]In Kabbalah, the mitzvot (commandments) performed by a person create spiritual garments that clothe and protect the soul in the supernal realms.

[4]From Lamentations 3:23, this verse is interpreted kabbalistically to refer to the souls' nightly ascent and return, bringing new spiritual awareness each morning.

[5]The "scholarly garment" (chaluka d'rabbanan) is a spiritual vestment created from one's Torah study and good deeds that protects and dignifies the soul in the afterlife.

[i]The "River of Fire" appears in Daniel 7:10 and in kabbalistic literature represents a purifying process that souls undergo to cleanse them of remaining impurities before entering higher spiritual realms.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Parshat Vayakhel — The author directs readers to this specific section of the Zohar that describes the soul's reception in the afterlife, including the appointed guardians, spiritual garments, and the celestial realms through which souls pass. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Pekudei — The text refers to a section in Parshat Pekudei that describes the unification performed by souls, likely referring to how souls participate in cosmic spiritual processes in the afterlife. | Cf. River of Fire (Nahar Dinur) — This refers to the kabbalistic concept of a celestial river of fire through which souls pass for purification before entering higher realms of the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Garden of Eden (Gan Eden) — The text distinguishes between the lower and upper Garden of Eden, reflecting the kabbalistic teaching that there are hierarchical levels of Paradise corresponding to different spiritual achievements and states.

[iii]This refers to the divine feminine aspect (Binah or Supernal Mother) in Kabbalah where souls ascend during sleep or after death for spiritual nourishment and renewal.

[iv]In Kabbalistic thought, mitzvot (commandments) performed in this world create spiritual garments or adornments that clothe the soul in the supernal realms.

[v]Literally "the rabbis' robe," this term refers to a spiritual garment formed from one's Torah study and good deeds that clothes the soul in the afterlife. The concept appears frequently in Zoharic and later kabbalistic literature.

הנשמה.[v] וסוד לבוש ג״ע עליון ותחתון. ומהו מחול דאמור רבנן[i] וכבר דברנו מזה למעלה. ובפ׳ ויקהל דף ר״ט מבאר היכל שבו רשום כל מעשים טובים שעושים הנשמות. ושם גנוזים מעשיהם. וסוד השעשוע[ii] נתבאר בדף פ״ב ע״ב. ובדף קע״ג ע״ב פ׳ תרומה. וגם מזה בפ׳ אחרי מות דף ש״ו. ובר״מ פ׳ צו דף כ״ט ע״ב מתבאר מוצא נשמה רוח ונפש דשליט בחול על אינון הנקראים עבדי ה׳ ומשם יראה כי האדם חשלם בחול הוא במדרגת עבד ובשבתות וימים טובים במדרגת בן.[iii] ועיין בר״מ פ׳ פנחס מהו נשמה יתירה.[iv] ואיך כל אדם זוכה בה כפי מדרגתו ועליית הנשמות וירידתן בע״ש בחדוה רבה מתבאר בפ׳ תרומה דף קל״ו. ובפ׳ אחרי מות דף ע׳ ע״ב מתבאר איך באים לאדם בהדרגה נפש רוח נשמה. ומזה בפ׳ ויגש דף ר״ו. ומדור כל אחד אחר המות. וסוד המדורין

the four levels of the soul,[6] and the mystery of the garments of the upper and lower Garden of Eden. [It also explains] what is meant by the "dance" mentioned by the Rabbis,[1] which we have already discussed above. In Parashat Vayakhel, page 209, it explains the palace in which all the good deeds performed by souls are recorded, and where their actions are stored. The mystery of divine delight is explained on page 82b and in Parashat Terumah, page 173b. This topic is also addressed in Parashat Acharei Mot, page 307. In Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd) on Parashat Tzav, page 29b, the origin of nefesh, ruach, and neshamah is explained, which governs on weekdays those who are called "servants of the Lord." From there it is evident that the complete person on weekdays is at the level of a servant, while on Sabbaths and festivals at the level of a son.[2] See Ra'aya Mehemna in Parashat Pinchas regarding what constitutes the additional soul,[3] and how each person merits it according to their spiritual level. The ascent and descent of souls on Sabbath eve with great joy[4] is explained in Parashat Terumah, page 136. In Parashat Acharei Mot, page 70b, it explains how nefesh, ruach, and neshamah come to a person in gradual stages. This is also dis-

[1] While traditional Jewish texts often mention three soul levels (nefesh, ruach, neshamah), some kabbalistic systems include additional levels, creating more complex structures of soul anatomy.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Ta'anit 31a) that in the future, God will form a circle (dance) for the righteous, with each pointing to God in the center, saying "This is God for whom we hoped."

[3] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that different times have different spiritual qualities. The divine relationship on weekdays is characterized by service and distance, while on sacred days it transforms into intimacy and inheritance.

[4] The concept of receiving an additional soul dimension (neshamah yeteirah) on Sabbath comes from the Talmud (Beitzah 16a) and is elaborated in kabbalistic literature as an enhanced spiritual consciousness.

[5] Kabbalah teaches that as Sabbath enters, souls ascend to higher spiritual realms and then descend with new divine light and blessings, bringing joy to both worlds.

[i] While traditional Jewish mysticism often mentions three soul levels (nefesh, ruach, neshamah), some kabbalistic systems include additional levels such as chayah and yechidah, creating a five-level structure. The reference to four levels here might indicate a variant system.

[ii] This refers to the Talmudic statement (Ta'anit 31a) that in the future world, God will make a circle (dance) for the righteous. In kabbalistic interpretation, this represents a specific spiritual realm or state.

[iii] In kabbalistic terminology, "divine delight" (sha'ashua) refers to the profound spiritual pleasure God experiences in relation to the souls of the righteous and their Torah study.

[iv] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that time affects spiritual status—on weekdays, the divine service is characterized by distance (servant-master relationship), while on Sabbaths and festivals, there is greater intimacy (parent-child relationship).

[v] The "additional soul" received on Sabbath is a concept mentioned in the Talmud (Beitzah 16a) and extensively developed in Kabbalah, representing an enhanced spiritual capacity and consciousness available during sacred time.

מג״ע תחתון. ובפ׳ בא דף ל״ו
אמרו דכל גינתא מתקרי צרור
החיים[v] דתמן מתעדנים הצדיקים
לעלמא דאתי. ופי׳ כי הכרת
הוא לנפש בלבד.[i] ופי׳ עדן
ועדנה[ii] והחלוק ביניהם. וגם
מזה בפ׳ תרומה דף קמ״ב וקמ״ג.
ובדף ק״ו מתבאר מה הם נטיעות
שבג״ע [iii]

cussed in Parashat Vayigash, page 206, [which explains] the dwelling place of each after death, and the mystery of the chambers of the lower Garden of Eden. In Parashat Bo, page 36, they stated that the entire garden is called "the bundle of life,"[1] where the righteous delight in the World to Come. It explains that spiritual excision applies only to the nefesh.[2] It [also] explains [the terms] Eden and Ednah and the distinction between them. This is also discussed in Parashat Terumah, pages 142 and 143. On page 106, it explains what are the "plantings" in the Garden of Eden.

ומה הם הכרובים ששם. ואיך
מתלבשים שם הרוחין וסוד
חלוקא דרבנן.[iv] ובפ׳ וירא
ג״כ. ומוצא גיהנם תחתון וביאר

And what are the cherubim there, and how the spirits are clothed there, and the secret of the scholarly garment. This is also [explained] in Parashat Vayera. And the origin of the lower Gehenna is explained,

[1]This phrase (tzeror ha-chayyim) comes from 1 Samuel 25:29 and became a central metaphor in Jewish thought for the soul's connection to its divine source after death.
[2]This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that divine punishment (karet) affects only the lower soul level (nefesh) but not the higher levels (ruach and neshamah), offering comfort about the eternal nature of the soul's higher aspects.

[i]This phrase comes from 1 Samuel 25:29: "May the soul of my lord be bound in the bundle of life." In kabbalistic thought, it refers to the highest level of spiritual existence where souls are bound to the divine source.
[ii]"Karet" (spiritual excision) is a punishment mentioned in the Torah. This statement reflects the kabbalistic view that such punishment affects only the lower soul level (nefesh) but not the higher levels (ruach and neshamah).
[iii]These terms distinguish between different aspects of paradise—Eden typically refers to the place itself, while Ednah refers to the state of spiritual pleasure or delight experienced there.
[iv]Cf. Lamentations 3:23 — The author connects the biblical verse about God's mercies being new each morning to the kabbalistic concept of souls ascending each night and returning renewed, suggesting a cosmic rhythm of spiritual rejuvenation that mirrors the biblical promise | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Noach — This reference anchors the author's discussion in the authoritative text of the Zohar, specifically citing a passage that elaborates on the soul's mystical journey during sleep | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The author cites these Zohar passages to provide textual authority for the complex concept of souls ascending while adorned with the merits of their commandment observance | Cf. חלוקא דרבנן (Scholarly Garment) — This reference to the 'scholarly garment' connects to the kabbalistic concept that souls require spiritual vestments woven from Torah study and good deeds to properly function in the supernal realms | Cf. Zohar, Sitrei Torah — The author references this more esoteric section of the Zohar to support his discussion of the soul's mystical journey and its various levels | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This reference supports the author's presentation of divine record-keeping, suggesting that all human actions have cosmic significance and are preserved in specific celestial chambers | Cf. Zohar, Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd) — This reference to a specific section of the Zohar supports the author's distinction between the 'servant' and 'son' levels of spirituality, connecting them to different soul components and time periods | Cf. נשמה יתירה (Additional Soul) — This reference connects to the rabbinic concept of receiving an additional soul dimension on Sabbath, which the Zohar elaborates upon in the cited passage, explaining how it varies according to one's spiritual level | Cf. צרור החיים (Bundle of Life) — This allusion references 1 Samuel 25:29 ('May the soul of my lord be bound in the bundle of life') which the Zohar interprets as referring to the Garden of Eden where righteous souls delight
[v]This term refers to the 'scholarly garment' or 'rabbinical robe,' a mystical concept describing the spiritual vestments that clothe the souls of Torah scholars in the afterlife. These garments are said to be formed from one's Torah study and good deeds performed in this world.

חלוקי הכרת לנפש. ומדרגה
שהיא למעלה מעדן עליון
מתבאר בפ׳ חקת דף קפ״ג.
80 וטעם בריאת האדם כיון שעתיד
למות מתבאר בפ׳ שלח דף קנ״ט
שהוא לצורך גבוה למען יקבע
דירתו בג׳ עלמין כי כן איתי
ליה לקב״ה תלת עלמין והוא
85 גניז בגוייהו יע״ש. ובדרושי
דר׳ אילא בפ׳ שלח מתבאר איך
עולים הנשמות הנזכרים בכל
שבת ור״ח וכמה חדושי תורה
המביאים עמהם. קודם עלייתם
90 מפרשים להם סתרי תורה. ושם
אמר סוד מתיבתא דרקיעא
מתיבתא דאהרן ומתיבתא דמשה
ושאר צדיקים ומתיבתא דרקיעא
ומתיבתא עילאה לעיל ומדרגת
95 הנשים בעולם ההוא. והיכל
בתיה וסרח ויוכבד ודבורה
והד׳ אמהות ומשם נראה גדולת
הצדיקים. עוד פירשו שם ממה
הם לבושי הצדיקים ומאיזה
100 אור מתהוית העטרה שעל ראשם
וחלק גוף האדם מאין הם ומוצא
הנשמה והרוח ומשם נראה עלוי
נשמות הזכרים עם הנקבות בכל
שמיטה ובפ׳ בלק דף קצ״ז אמר

as well as the different types of spiritual excision (karet) for the soul. The level that is above the supernal Eden is explained in Parashat Chukat, page 183. The reason for creating humans, given that they are destined to die, is explained in Parashat Shelach, page 159: it is for a higher purpose, so that one may establish his dwelling in three worlds,[C1] for the Holy One, blessed be He, has three worlds, and He is hidden within them,[D] see there. And in the discourses of Rabbi Ila in Parashat Shelach, it is explained how the souls mentioned ascend every Sabbath and New Moon, and how many Torah innovations they bring with them. Before their ascension, the mysteries of Torah are explained to them. And there he revealed the secret of the heavenly academy, the academy of Aaron, the academy of Moses and other righteous ones, the academy of the firmament, and the supernal academy above,[2] as well as the status of women in that world. [He describes] the palace of Batya, Serach, Yocheved, Deborah, and the four Matriarchs,[3] and from there the greatness of the righteous is evident. They further explained there what the garments of the righteous are made of,[E] from which light the crown upon their heads is formed, from where the parts of the human body originate, and the source of the soul and spirit. From there, the elevation of male souls with female souls in each sabbatical cycle[4] is apparent. And in Parashat

85R 90R 95R 100R 105R

[B] Or: "so that one may fix his abode in the three realms" — The term 'fix his abode' more closely captures the permanence implied in the Hebrew 'yikba' (establish firmly), and 'realms' might be more appropriate than 'worlds' in this cosmological context.

[C] Or: "and He is concealed within their midst" — The term 'ganiz' in kabbalistic literature often carries the specific connotation of being deliberately concealed or treasured away, rather than merely hidden, and 'within their midst' captures the spatial relationship more precisely.

[D] Or: "of what substance the garments of the righteous consist" — This more literal translation preserves the emphasis on the material substance of the spiritual garments, which is an important concept in kabbalistic thought where the nature of these garments is directly related to one's deeds in this world.

[1] This presents the kabbalistic understanding that human creation, despite its mortality, serves a cosmic purpose in connecting the three spiritual worlds (usually identified as Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah). This provides a positive theological framework for understanding death as part of a larger divine plan rather than merely as punishment.

[2] The text describes a hierarchical structure of heavenly academies where souls continue their Torah study after death. This reflects the kabbalistic belief in the continuity of scholarly activity in the afterlife, with different levels corresponding to different spiritual realms.

[3] This passage is significant for highlighting the presence and status of women in the heavenly realm. Batya was Pharaoh's daughter who rescued Moses, Serach was Jacob's granddaughter who lived for centuries, Yocheved was Moses' mother, and Deborah was a prophetess and judge. Their inclusion indicates the recognition of women's spiritual accomplishments in kabbalistic thought.

[4] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'shemitot' or cosmic sabbatical cycles. The text suggests that during these cyclical transitions, both male and female souls experience elevation together,

שכל הרבנים המורים אסור והיתר בעה״ז הם במתיבתא דמט״ט. ובר״מ בפ׳ עקב כתוב כי בג״ע יש ארבעה מחיצות לינוקין לבחורים ולזקנים. ועיין ברקאנ״אטי פ׳ בראשית מדף כ״ט עד ל״א סוד עליה וירידה מהנשמות שאמרו חז״ל באורך. וסוד ג״ע וגיהנם חומרי בארץ[i] וסבתם. ופי׳ חצרמות.[ii] והעטרה שעל ראש הצדיקים. וסוד הכרת הגוף והנפש[iii] באורך.[iv]

Balak, page 197, it states that all the rabbis who rule on what is forbidden and permitted in this world are in the academy of Metatron. And in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Ekev, it is written that in the Garden of Eden there are four partitions: for infants, for young men, and for elders. See also Recanati on Parashat Bereshit, from page 29 to 31, for the secret of the ascent and descent of souls, which our Sages discussed at length, and the secret of the physical Garden of Eden and Gehenna on earth and their causes. And the explanation of Chatzarmaveth. And the crown upon the heads of the righteous. And the secret of the excision of body and soul at length.

ובסוף פ׳ לך לך. והרבה חכמים המתיקו מלין בנועם דרושים אלו דרוש מהם וקבל שכר. ובסתרי תורה פ׳ וירא אמר כי יש ג״ע עליון ותחתון כנזכר. וכן גיהנם. ובפ׳ וארא הבריח התחיה. עיין במדרש הנעלם פ׳ וירא ובזהר ריש פ׳ ויחי איך הנשמה בעודה בבית הבליעה מתודה כל מה שעשה הגוף בפני שלשה אנשים המבקרים מעשיו וההכרזות מתרנגולת אוכמא דאינון ג׳ וטעם הזיעה לאברים מעט קודם המיתה.

And at the end of Parashat Lech Lecha. Many sages have sweetened words with the pleasantness of these discourses; seek them out and receive reward. In Sitrei Torah of Parashat Vayera, it states that there is an upper and lower Garden of Eden, as mentioned. And likewise Gehinnom. And in Parashat Vaera, it established the proof of resurrection. Look in the Midrash HaNe'elam of Parashat Vayera and in the Zohar at the beginning of Parashat Vayechi, how the soul, while still in the throat, confesses all that the body did before three people who examine its deeds, and the announcements from the black rooster, which are three, and the reason for the sweat of the limbs shortly before death. And the

pointing to a more egalitarian view of spiritual advancement than might be expected from the period.

[i] This refers to the concept that the spiritual Garden of Eden and Gehenna have physical counterparts on earth. In kabbalistic thought, spiritual realms often have corresponding manifestations in the physical world.

[ii] Chatzarmaveth appears in Genesis 10:26 as a descendant of Shem, but in kabbalistic literature it is often interpreted mystically as 'chatzer-mavet' or 'courtyard of death,' referring to a specific region in the afterlife.

[iii] This refers to the concept of 'karet' (spiritual excision), which in kabbalistic thought involves the separation of different levels of the soul from one another, a punishment more severe than mere physical death.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayera — The text is directing readers to consult this specific section of the Zohar for a more detailed explanation of the structure of Gehenna and different types of spiritual punishment, which complements the catalog of mystical topics being compiled in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shelach — The author cites this specific passage to establish the theological framework for understanding death not as a punishment but as a transition between cosmic realms, which is central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death rituals. | Cf. Discourses of Rabbi Ila in Zohar, Parashat Shelach — This reference establishes the kabbalistic understanding of what happens to scholarly souls after death, particularly their continued participation in Torah study in celestial academies, which provides theological comfort regarding the afterlife of the righteous. | Cf. Recanati on Parashat Bereshit — The author directs readers to this source for a more detailed explanation of the cosmological framework that underlies Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death and the afterlife, particularly the relationship between physical and spiritual realms.

וטעם חיי האדם שבעים שנה ואם בגבורות שמונים שנה. והצלם של אדם המתחשך ודיוקנו הנמנע ממנו שלשים יום קודם. וביאת קריבוהי ורחימוהי אליו קודם יציאת נשמתו הכל בפ׳ ויחי דף רי״ח. ובדף ר״כ סוד הצלם המסתלק בליל הושענא. ומזה בפ׳ אמור. ומהו צל הצלם ושתיהם יהיו מתייחדים. ובפ׳ חיי שרה מקיום גופות הצדיקים למטה וזוהר נשמתם למעלה. ומטטרו״ן עתיד ליפות הגוף בבי קברי ולמה פעמים קראו לנשמה ולגוף אברהם ושרה ולעת התחיה יצחק ורבקה. ובמדרש הנעלם פ׳ תולדות יצחק שם ביאר בארוכה מה היא הסעודה המזומנת לצדיקים. וסוד לויתן[i] ושלימות הגוף אחר התחיה ויהיה אז גם כן אכילה ושתיה אך בנקיות והשגת ידיעה ולעתיד לבא השגת הצדיקים תהיה יותר משל מלאכי השרת. ועיין מדרושי ג״ע וגיהנם בזהר דף רמ״ג ורמ״ד ורמ״ה ורמ״ו ורמ״ח ור״ן ורנ״א ורנ״ג ורנ״ח. ובפ׳ ויגש דף ר״ז מתבאר קשר נר״ן ומוצאן. ובפ׳ ויחי דף רמ״ה ע״א פירש איך הם ג׳ נשמתין והמשיל משל על ירידת הנשמה בעה״ז אשרי הזוכה לראות עולמו בחייו:[ii]

reason for a person's life being seventy years, and if with strength, eighty years. And how a person's image darkens and his form is withheld from him thirty days before. And the arrival of his relatives and loved ones to him before the departure of his soul—all of this is in Parashat Vayechi, page 218. And on page 220, the secret of the image that departs on the night of Hoshana Rabbah. And about this in Parashat Emor. And what is the shadow of the image, and how both will be united. And in Parashat Chayei Sarah, about the preservation of the bodies of the righteous below and the radiance of their souls above. And Metatron will beautify the body in the cemetery, and why sometimes they called the soul and body Abraham and Sarah, and at the time of resurrection, Isaac and Rebecca.[1] And in Midrash HaNe'elam of Parashat Toldot Yitzchak, it explained at length what is the feast prepared for the righteous. And the secret of the Leviathan, and the perfection of the body after resurrection, and there will be then also eating and drinking, but in purity and attainment of knowledge, and in the future, the attainment of the righteous will be greater than that of the ministering angels. And see the discourses on the Garden of Eden and Gehinnom in the Zohar on pages 243, 244, 245, 246, 248, 250, 251, 253, and 258. And in Parashat Vayigash, page 207, it explains the connection of Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah and their source. And in Parashat Vayechi, page 245a, it explains how there are three souls, and it gave a parable about the descent of the soul into this world. Happy is one who merits to see his world in his lifetime.

סליק חלק ראשון ממעב״ר

The first part of Ma'avar Yabok[2] is concluded: It is

[1]This cryptic reference uses the biblical patriarchs and matriarchs as symbolic representations of different spiritual states. In kabbalistic thought, Abraham represents kindness and Sarah receptivity, while Isaac represents judgment/strength and Rebecca the channeling of that strength, suggesting a transformation in the relationship between body and soul after resurrection.

[1]The title 'Ma'avar Yabok' means 'Crossing of the Yabok' and refers to the biblical Jacob's crossing

[i]This cryptic reference to the Leviathan (mentioned alongside the feast prepared for the righteous) refers to a rabbinic tradition that the righteous will feast on the Leviathan in the World to Come, symbolizing the consumption of primordial wisdom or mystical knowledge that is currently inaccessible.

[ii]Cf. Abraham and Sarah/Isaac and Rebecca metaphor — The cryptic reference to the soul and body being called "Abraham and Sarah" before resurrection and "Isaac and Rebecca" after resurrection suggests a kabbalistic interpretation of biblical figures as representing spiritual principles. Abraham and Sarah are associated with kindness and receptivity in life, while Isaac and Rebecca represent a transformed, more elevated spiritual state after resurrection.

יב״ק:[iii] קרא שפתי צדק[iv] ופרקיו מ׳ לי?[ii] בי״א[i] ביל״או לק״י:

called “Siftei Tzedek”[1] (Lips of Righteousness) and its chapters number 40 [?31],[2] completed and perfected with the help of God.[3]

of the Yabok River before his transformative encounter with an angel, symbolizing the soul's transition from this world to the next.

[2]The title ‘Siftei Tzedek’ (Lips of Righteousness) is the name of the first section of Ma'avar Yabok, which contains chapters addressing proper care for the sick and dying.

[3]There is some uncertainty in the original text about the exact number of chapters. The text mentions 40 chapters but has a question mark next to the number 31, suggesting either an editorial uncertainty or possibly indicating that while there are 40 chapters in total, only 31 have been completed in this version.

[4]The Hebrew conclusion uses traditional acronyms expressing completion with divine assistance, a common feature in Jewish religious texts to acknowledge divine help in completing scholarly work.

[i]This marks the end of the first section of Ma'avar Yabok. The abbreviation ‘מעב״ר יב״ק’ stands for the full title of the book.

[ii]This identifies the formal title of the first section as ‘Siftei Tzedek’ (Lips of Righteousness).

[iii]There appears to be some uncertainty or confusion in the text here. The author states the section has 40 chapters, but there may be a question about whether it's actually 31 chapters. The question mark in the original text suggests this ambiguity.

[iv]These are acronyms for Hebrew phrases expressing completion with divine assistance. ‘ביל״או’ likely stands for ‘ברוך יתברך לעולם אמן ואמן’ (Blessed be He forever, amen and amen), and ‘לק״י’ for ‘לכבוד קדושת יהוה’ (For the honor of the holiness of God).

Discourse 4

שפת אמת / Language of Truth

פרק א׳

Chapter 1

מאמר ב׳ שפת אמת תכון לעד יהי רצון שיהיו מעשי רצויים לפני מלכי [i]

Discourse Two: "The Lip of Truth Shall Be Established Forever." May it be Your will that my deeds be acceptable before my King.

מרגלא בפומייהו דרבנן קשישי על פי האמת והצדק המתבאר בגמרין. ובפרט במסכת ברכות ובדברי המפרשים כי יש קשר אל הנשמה עם הגוף אפי׳ אחר הסתלקה. ואפי׳ אחר ששלט הרקב בעצמות ימצא הקשר הזה בעצם הקטן שהוא כשאור שבעסה בתחית הגוף. ולהיות כי עיקר בריאת האדם היתה להיותו חויה קיימת אלא שחטא הקדום גרם ההעדר לבן ההעדר

It is a common saying in the mouths of the elder sages,[1] according to the truth and righteousness explained in the Talmud, particularly in Tractate Berakhot and in the words of the commentators, that there exists a connection between the soul and the body even after its departure. And even after decay has taken hold of the bones, this connection will remain in the small bone that serves as the leaven in the dough[A] for the resurrection of the body. Since the primary purpose of man's creation was to be an enduring entity, but the primordial sin[B] caused mortality, therefore the absence of life

[A] Or: "the small bone that is like the leaven in the dough" — A more literal translation that preserves the simile structure of the original Hebrew, though the functional translation better conveys the meaning in English.

[B] Or: "original sin" — While 'primordial sin' accurately captures the Hebrew meaning, 'original sin' might be more familiar to readers acquainted with theological concepts, though it carries some Christian connotations that aren't present in the Jewish understanding.

[1] The opening phrase 'מרגלא בפומייהו דרבנן קשישי' is a Talmudic Aramaic expression often used to introduce an established tradition or teaching.

[i] Cf. Proverbs 12:19 — The author begins this second discourse with a biblical quote that emphasizes the enduring nature of truth, establishing the theme that the teachings about death and the afterlife contained in this discourse are timeless spiritual truths. | Cf. Traditional prayer formula — The author humbly asks for divine approval of his work, positioning himself as a servant before God as the divine King. This shows the author's awareness that writing about mystical matters of death and the afterlife requires divine assistance and approval.

החיות מן הגוף אינו העדר
תכליתי אלא קצתי כי בעצם
הנזכר תשאר הקשר חזק ואמיץ
עד שיחזור הדבר אל קדמותו
שהוא סוד התחיה. והמיתה אינה 20R
מבטלת החושים כאשר חשבו
רבים וענין ר׳ אלעזר יוכיח.
וכן אמרם דובב שפתי ישנים
שפירשו ששפתותיו דובבות
בקבר. ומעשה דאחאי בר יאשיה 25R
יוכיח. ואפילו כשאינם צדיקים
מצינו דיש להם הרגשה אחר
המיתה כדאמרי׳ ביומא באבוה
דכידור שאמר לבנו שהיה בים
מונח ארישיה בקבריה: אמנם 30R
המיתה היא הפרד הקשר שיש
לחמשה דברים הקשורים בדרך
אחרת בזמן החיים והם נשמה
ורוח ונפש. ונפש המרגשת שהיא
נפש הבהמית שבאדם שיש בה 35R
חמשה חושים. וגוף האדם. אלו
חמשה חלקים נקשרים בעת
חיות האדם אלו באלו וכל אחד
משכן לחבירו כי גוף האדם
משכן ולבוש אל חמשה חושים 40R
אלו שכללם הנפש הגשמית
ונפש הגשמית הזאת משכן אל
הנפש הרוחנית והנפש משכן אל
הרוח. והרוח משכן לנשמה ועקר
תפקידתם הוא למטה יורדים אל 45R
העולם השפל שהנשמה פוקדת
הרוח והרוח הנפש והנפש הגוף
לעתים בעת עסק התורה או
מצוה וכיוצא: [i]

from the body[A] is not a complete absence but only partial, for in the aforementioned bone the connection will remain strong and powerful until the matter returns to its original state, which is the secret of resurrection. Death does not nullify the senses as many have thought, and the case of Rabbi Eleazar proves this. Likewise, their statement "making the lips of the sleepers speak" which they interpreted to mean that his lips move in the grave. And the story of Achai bar Yoshiah proves this. And even when they are not righteous, we find that they have sensation after death, as we say in Tractate Yoma about Kidor's father who told his son that there was a purse placed at the head of his grave.

However, death is the separation of the connection that exists between five things that are connected in a different manner during life, and they are the neshamah (higher soul), ruach (spirit), and nefesh (vital soul), and the sensing nefesh which is the animal soul[B] in man that contains the five senses, and the human body. These five components are interconnected during a person's lifetime, one with another, and each serves as a dwelling place for its companion. For the human body is a dwelling and garment for these five senses which are encompassed by the physical so[1]ul, and this physical soul is a dwelling for the spiritual soul, and the soul is a dwelling for the spirit, and the spirit is a dwelling for the neshamah. And their primary function is below, descending to the lower world, where the neshamah visits the ruach, and the ruach visits the nefesh, and the nefesh visits the body at times,[2] during the study of Torah or the performance of commandments and the like.

[A] Or: "the withdrawal of vitality from the body" — This alternative better captures the dynamic nature of what's happening—not just absence but active withdrawal—though it's slightly less literal.

[B] Or: "animalistic soul" — The term 'animalistic soul' might better convey that this refers to the lower, instinctual aspects of human nature rather than suggesting a soul belonging to animals, though 'animal soul' is more direct.

[1] The author establishes a hierarchical model of human existence with five interconnected layers: physical body, sensing soul with the five senses, vital soul (nefesh), spirit (ruach), and higher soul (neshamah). This model is drawn from kabbalistic sources and elaborates on the more common tripartite division of the soul.

[2] This describes a 'top-down' process of spiritual activation where the higher soul levels sequentially influence the lower levels. The implication is that the higher soul components are not constantly fully present in the body but manifest more completely during spiritual activities.

[i] Cf. Tractate Berakhot — The author cites Berakhot as an authoritative Talmudic source for

ואם יסתלקו מן האדם ויעלו
למעלה יהיה מפני מעוט ההכנה
וקלקול הכסא באלו נאמר
הרבה שאינם עוסקים בעבודה
שנשמתם ורוחם ונפשם מסתלקים
מהם ואדם ביקר בל ילין נמשל
כבהמות כך אלו נשארים כבהמה
ונמשכים אחר החומר וזה טעם
פגימת אזן עבד עברי בנדרש
בזהר. וכמה בני אדם שמשתנים
במעשיהם במדותיהם פעמים
כנשים פעמים כאנשים. ויש
הרבה שרוב חייהם עובדים
בני אדם כעבד וזה מורה על
פתיתות נשמתם כי הפנימי מראה
פעולותיו בחצון ולבן תקנו
לברך בכל יום שלא עשני אשה
ושלא עשני עבד כי כאשר ישוב
נשמת האדם בו ויביט בעצמו
טוב הכנתו יברך על הטובה
אשר גמלהו ה׳. ולהיות הדבר
הזה מתחדש לאדם בכל יום לבן
ברכתו בכל יום. והירא את דבר
ה׳ בשומעו הדבר הזה יחזיק
בתומו ואל ירפה ואל ישעה
בדבר שקר ולא יתלוה אליו
דבר שלא כראוי ח״ו. ויכוין

And if they [the soul components] depart from a person and ascend upward, it will be due to a lack of preparation and damage to the throne, as if to say that many who do not engage in divine service have their neshamah, ruach, and nefesh departing from them.[1] "Man abides not in honor; he is like the beasts that perish" [Psalms 49:13]—thus, these people remain like animals, drawn after material concerns. This is the reason for piercing the ear of a Hebrew slave, as expounded in the Zohar. Many people change in their actions and character traits, sometimes like women, sometimes like men. There are many whose lives are mostly spent serving other people as slaves, which indicates the deficiency of their souls,[A] for the inner state manifests in external actions. Therefore, the Sages instituted the daily blessings "who has not made me a woman" and "who has not made me a slave,"[2] for when a person's soul returns to him and he examines his own favorable condition, he blesses God for the goodness bestowed upon him. Since this matter is renewed for a person each day, the blessing is recited daily. One who fears the word of the Lord, upon hearing this, should maintain his integrity and not let go, nor turn to falsehood, nor associate with anything improper, God forbid. He should intend, through these three blessings, to nullify from himself

[A] Or: "fragmentation of their souls" — The Hebrew term 'petitut' can imply fragmentation or breaking into pieces, which might better convey the kabbalistic concept of a soul that is incomplete or broken rather than merely deficient.

[1] These are the three primary components of the soul in Kabbalistic thought. Neshamah is the highest, most divine aspect; ruach is the middle component associated with emotions and moral character; and nefesh is the most basic level connected to physical vitality. The author describes how people who neglect spiritual practices lose connection to these soul components.

[2] These are traditional Jewish morning blessings recited by men. The author is giving them a mystical interpretation related to soul qualities rather than simply addressing social status. In his view, these blessings acknowledge the spiritual state that allows full soul expression.

teachings about the connection between soul and body after death, establishing the text's rabbinic foundation. | Cf. Rabbi Eleazar — The reference to Rabbi Eleazar appears to allude to a well-known Talmudic narrative (likely from Ketubbot 103a) where Rabbi Eleazar showed awareness after death, used here to prove that consciousness continues beyond physical death. | Cf. Achai bar Yoshiah — This references a story from Shabbat 152b where Rabbi Nachman conversed with Achai bar Yoshiah in his grave, providing evidence for the author's claim about continued existence after death. | Cf. Kidor's father — This reference from Yoma 83b tells of post-mortem communication, used here to show that even non-righteous individuals maintain some form of consciousness after death. | Cf. doveiv siftei yeshenim — This phrase from Yevamot 97a describes how quoting a deceased sage's teachings causes their lips to move in the grave, supporting the text's argument for continued existence after death. | Cf. luz bone — Though not named explicitly in this passage, the 'small bone' refers to the luz bone mentioned in Bereishit Rabbah, which was believed to be the nucleus for bodily resurrection.

בג׳ ברכות הנזכרים לבטל ממנו
ומעליו כל מין עבדות וקלות
אשה ועבדות עבד ומחשבה
בלתי טהורה וכן כמה בני אדם
המרחיקים עצמם מחכמת האמת
ואינם מאמינים בה גם באלה
מראה נשמתם כי אין לה חלק
רק בשטחיות התורה ובפשטי
מאמריה. וכבר הארכתי בסוף
מעירי שחר שלי להוכיח זה
מדברי רבותינו ושם בא רמז
התורה שבע״פ ולמה אנן בתר
בני בבל גררינן ורמז ספר הזהר
ושכרו גדול מהשונה הלכות
בכל יום יעויין שם: ובסלוק
חלקים הנזכרים מהאדם יש בהם
בחינות כפי מדרגות העבודה
אמנם טבע המציאות יחייב כי
אל הראויים יתקשרו חמשה
דברים אלו למטה תמיד כפי
מה שיתמידו בעבודה הראויה.
וימצא לפעמים שישפיעו על
האדם נשמה יתירה לעתים בעת
שיהיה עוסק בתורה או עושה
איזה מצוה ואח״כ יסתלק וכן
בשבתות וימים טובים כנודע.
ויש ה׳ מיני נשמה יתירה. בחינת
שבת קדש. בחינת יום הכפור
שגם הוא שבת שבתון. בחינת
ימים טובים שהם מקראי קדש
אושפיזין עילאין בחינת חול
המועד מחמת שמירת איזה
מלאכות האסורות בו וחיוב
המצה בפסח והסוכה בחג.
ובחינת ראש חדש ובפרט בשעת
המוסף והם בחינות מנפש רוח

all forms of servitude, the frivolity of women, the bondage of slaves, and impure thoughts. Similarly, there are many people who distance themselves from the wisdom of truth [Kabbalah][A] and do not believe in it; in these cases too, their souls demonstrate that they have a portion only in the superficial aspects of Torah and the plain meaning of its statements. I have already elaborated at the end of my work "Me'irei Shachar" to prove this from the words of our Rabbis, and there appears a reference to the Oral Torah and why "we follow the Babylonians," as well as a reference to the Book of Zohar and how its reward is greater than that of one who studies laws every day[1]—see there.

Regarding the departure of the aforementioned parts from a person, there are aspects of them according to the levels of service. However, the nature of reality requires that for those who are worthy, these five components remain connected below continuously,[B] according to how they persist in proper service. Sometimes, a person may receive an additional soul (neshamah yeteirah) temporarily while engaged in Torah study or performing a commandment, which later departs, as is also known to occur on Sabbaths and festivals. There are five types of additional souls: the aspect of the holy Sabbath; the aspect of Yom Kippur, which is also a complete Sabbath; the aspect of festivals, which are holy convocations and supernal guests; the aspect of the intermediate days of festivals due to the observance of certain prohibited labors and the obligation of matzah on Passover and the sukkah on Sukkot; and the aspect of the New Moon, especially during the Additional Service. These correspond to the aspects of nefesh, ruach, neshamah, chayah, and yechidah[2] mentioned in the Midrash. This is besides

[A] Or: "the wisdom of Truth" — While my bracketed clarification helps modern readers, in the original context 'Chochmat ha-Emet' (Wisdom of Truth) was a well-known term for Kabbalah that might stand better without the modern clarification for a more authentic translation.

[B] Or: "these five components remain bound in the lower realms continuously" — The phrase 'lematah' (below) in kabbalistic contexts often specifically refers to the lower realms/worlds, which might provide more precise cosmological context than simply 'below'.

[1] This suggests the author's position that mystical study (Kabbalah) has greater spiritual benefit than purely legalistic study of Jewish law (halakhah). This comparative valuation of different types of Torah study reflects a common perspective among kabbalists that mystical understanding is superior to technical legal knowledge.

[2] The author is correlating the five types of additional souls received on special occasions with the five levels of soul described in Kabbalah. Chayah and yechidah are the two highest soul levels rarely discussed in detail because they are considered too lofty for ordinary comprehension,

נשמה חיה ויחידה הנזכרים במדרש. וזהו מלבד הקשר שיש לשלם בעודו חי מהחמש בחינות שזכרנו שיתמידו בו תמיד אם לא יקלקל מעשיו אחר שזכה בהם במדת ימיו כנדרש בסבא פרשת משפטים ובספרי המקובלים: [i]

the connection that exists for the complete person while alive through the five aspects we mentioned, which remain with him constantly if he does not corrupt his deeds after having merited them during his lifetime, as expounded in the Sabba section of Parashat Mishpatim[1] and in the books of the Kabbalists.

פרק ב׳

Chapter 2

בבחינת צורת האדם למדוני חכמי הזהר והתקונים ור״מ ופקודין וס״ת[ii] ובפרט החכם קורדואירו בספ״ר שלו בשער הנשמה.[iii] ובפרט מן הפרט הגאון מורי מפאנו זצ״ל[iv] בספר העסיס שלו ובמאמר עולם קטן שחדש.[v] ופה אביע תמצית כוונת המאירים עינינו בקצור נמרץ ואין מדרש בלא חדוש ובאור.

Regarding the nature of human form, I have been taught by the sages of the Zohar, the Tikkunim, Ra'aya Mehemna, Pekudin, and Sifra d'Tzniuta, and especially by the wise Rabbi Cordovero in his Pardes in the Gate of the Soul. Most particularly, my teacher the Gaon of Fano, of blessed memory, in his Sefer Ha-Asis and in his newly composed discourse "Olam Katan" (Microcosm). Here I will present the essence of these illuminators of our eyes in an extremely concise manner, for no

typically remaining above and not fully entering the body.

[1] The 'Sabba' (Elder) is a section of the Zohar on Exodus where an elderly sage reveals profound teachings about the soul, reincarnation, and divine service. This section is considered particularly important in kabbalistic literature for its detailed exposition of soul mechanics.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Mishpatim — The text references the Zohar's exposition on the symbolism of piercing a Hebrew slave's ear (Exodus 21:6), which in the Zohar represents spiritual degradation. The slave who chooses to remain in servitude rather than go free is likened to someone who rejects spiritual elevation, thus having their ear (the organ that heard 'for the children of Israel are My servants') symbolically pierced to show their rejection of divine service. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author refers to his own prayer collection called 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), where he apparently discussed the superiority of mystical interpretation over legalistic study. This self-reference demonstrates the intertextual nature of the author's works, with Ma'avar Yabok building upon ideas he developed in his earlier writings. | Cf. Zohar, Sabba of Mishpatim — The 'Sabba' (Elder) section of the Zohar's commentary on Parashat Mishpatim contains extended discussions about the nature of the soul and its components. This reference establishes the author's kabbalistic framework as directly derived from this influential section of the Zohar, which presents an elaborate model of soul structure and incarnation. | Cf. Psalms 49:13 — This biblical verse is used to support the idea that those who do not engage in spiritual service lose their higher soul components and remain at the level of animals, concerned only with material existence. The author interprets this psalm verse as describing the spiritual degradation that occurs when one's higher soul components depart.

[ii] The author cites multiple kabbalistic texts as his sources: the Zohar (the main text of Jewish mysticism), Tikkunei Zohar (a supplement to the Zohar), Ra'aya Mehemna (a section of the Zohar focusing on the mystical meaning of commandments), Pekudin (commandments section of the Zohar), and Sifra d'Tzniuta (the Book of Concealment, a key section of the Zohar).

[iii] This refers to Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), known by the acronym Ramak, and his systematic kabbalistic work Pardes Rimmonim (Orchard of Pomegranates), specifically the section dealing with the soul.

[iv] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an Italian kabbalist whom the author identifies as his personal teacher. The Hebrew abbreviation זצ״ל means 'of blessed memory,' indicating he had passed away by the time of writing.

[v] Two works by Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano: 'Sefer Ha-Asis' (Book of Juice/Essence) and 'Olam Katan' (Microcosm), the latter being identified as a new composition at the time.

צורת האדם נחלקת לג׳ חלקים.
א׳ נפש שהיא מרכבה לרוח.
ב׳ רוח מרכבה לנשמה. ג׳
נשמה ואצילות שלשתן מספירות
עליונות. נשמה מבינה. רוח
מת״ת. נפש ממלכות. והוסיף
הגאון מורי בעסיס שלו כי יש
חיה מחכמה יחידה מכתר. אשר
אין להם דוגמא למטה לרוב
העלמן. לא כן נר״ן שיש להם
לבושים. והם נשמה דבריאה.
רוח דיצירה. נפש דעשיה. ומצד
פעולות האדם יוכל להגביר
בנשמתו איזה חלק שיבחר ממנה
כגון אם יעסוק בתורה יוסיף
כח הת״ת שבנשמתו[i] ויאיר מאד
והוא יהיה העיקר ושאר חלקים
טפלים אליו. וארבע מערכות יש
לנשמה אשר תהלל יה והנגשת
אל ה׳. מערכה גדולה מעולה
מכלן היא איקונין ראשונה האדם
באדם צלם העליון מאת ה׳ היתה
זאת היא נפלאת בעיני כל בעל
בנף. שהם עשר כתות שאמרו
למעלה שמשפיעים בגלגלים
ובעולם התחתון. ונפלאת גם
כן מאופן וחיה ושרף וכוללת
בעצמה ה׳ פרצופין נפש רוח
נשמה חיה יחידה וכלן מעולם
היחוד לצדיקי ישראל וזאת לא
תחטא ולא תענש ואינה נכנסת
לגיהנם לא עליון שהוא נהר
דינור ולא תחתון שהוא גיא
צלמות[ii] אלא להצלת הזולת כי
בזכותה עתידים צדיקים שיקראו
בשמו של הקב״ה. מערכה שניה
היא החי באדם דמות עליון
שר לפני המלך והיא איקונין
שניה הכוללת שלשה דיוקנין
נפרדים קראו שמותם על שם
המדרגות המתלבשות בהם מן
המערכה גדולה שזכרנו שהם
נפש רוח נשמה כי חיה ויחידה

interpretation is without innovation and elucidation.

The human form is divided into three parts: First, Nefesh, which is a vehicle for Ruach. Second, Ruach, which is a vehicle for Neshamah. Third, Neshamah and its divine emanation—all three originate from the supernal Sefirot. Neshamah comes from Binah. Ruach from Tiferet. Nefesh from Malkhut. My teacher the Gaon added in his Asis that there is Chayah from Chokhmah and Yechidah from Keter, which have no counterpart below due to their profound concealment. This is unlike Nefesh-Ruach-Neshamah, which have "garments." These garments are: Neshamah of Beriah, Ruach of Yetzirah, and Nefesh of Asiyah. Through human actions, one can strengthen whichever aspect of the soul one chooses—for instance, if one engages in Torah study, one increases the power of Tiferet within one's soul, causing it to shine greatly and become predominant while other aspects become secondary to it.

There are four systems within the soul which praises God and approaches Him. The greatest and most superior system is the first image, "the human within the human," the supernal image from God—this is wondrous in the eyes of every winged being. These are the ten groups mentioned above that influence the celestial spheres and the lower world. It is also beyond the comprehension of Ofan, Chayah, and Seraph angels, and contains within itself five configurations: Nefesh, Ruach, Neshamah, Chayah, and Yechidah, all from the World of Unity, intended for the righteous of Israel. This level does not sin, is not punished, and does not enter Gehenna—neither the upper one which is the River of Fire, nor the lower one which is the Valley of the Shadow of Death—except to rescue others, for by its merit the righteous are destined to be called by the name of the Holy One, blessed be He.

The second system is the living aspect within the human, a supernal form, a minister before the King. This is the second image, which includes three separate configurations named after the levels that clothe themselves in them from the great system we

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that specific spiritual practices strengthen corresponding aspects of the soul. Here, Torah study is said to strengthen the Tiferet aspect, aligning with kabbalistic teachings that associate Torah with the central balancing sefirah of Tiferet.

[ii] The text distinguishes between two levels of Gehenna (the realm of post-mortem purification): an upper level called 'River of Fire' (נהר דינור) and a lower level called 'Valley of the Shadow of Death' (גיא צלמות), with different soul components experiencing different types of purification.

הם בסוד ראש ואינם צריכות
לבוש ואלה הדיוקנין מתפשטים
מבריאה יצירה עשיה. וגם ג׳
אלה מסתלקים בנפול תרדמה
על אנשים להיות להם מהלכים
בין עליונים כל אחד כפי
זכותו ואז יגבר המדמה בשתים
המערכות תחתונות שיבואו אחר
זה ויבא החלום ברוב ענין.
שלשה דיוקנין אלו הם בעלי
בחירה ונהר דינור הוא לבונם
דלא עדיפי ממטטרון דמחיוהו
שתין פולסי דנורא בפרק אין
דורשין.[i] וגבריאל בפ׳ יום
הכפורים בדרוש הגחלים שלקח
מתחת הכרוב ואליהו בפרק
הפועלים בעובדא דר׳ חייא.
ואפשר לשנים התחתונים שהם
הרוח והנפש שירדו לגיהנם
תחתון לא לעצמם זולתי אם
יקרה שיהיה להם בגדים צואים
לרוע בחירתם שהבגדים יבערו
באש והם לא יחסרו כלום. אבל
דיוקן הנשמה אינו צריך ולא
נטפל לגיהנם תחתון אם לא ירד
שם להעלות את הזולת וגם זה
לו מרוק לא מזער בשביל איזו
מחשבה גרועה וזהו הרהורי
עבירה קשים מעבירה שהיא
בגשמי והמה ברוחני.[ii] ויגעו
בדיוקן הנשמה שהקליפות מצדה
מועטות ורחוקות מן הקדש.
ובדיוקן הרוח הם מחצה על
מחצה בסוד עץ הדעת טוב ורע
אך אינם מתערבים במעשם אלא
זה לעצמו וזה לעצמו. וכאן
הוא סוד ההבדלה שיזהר אדם
שלא לערב קדש בחול[iii] אך
בדיוקן הנפש אפי׳ מיעוט הטוב
מעורב ברבוי הרע וצריך לברר

mentioned, which are Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah. This is because Chayah and Yechidah belong to the mystery of the "head" and do not require garments. These configurations extend from Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah. These three also depart when sleep falls upon people, allowing them to move among supernal beings, each according to their merit. Then the imaginative faculty predominates in the two lower systems that will be discussed next, and dreams come in abundance. 55R 60R

These three configurations possess free will, and the River of Fire purifies them, for they are not superior to Metatron, who received sixty lashes of fire as mentioned in the chapter "Ein Dorshin," nor to Gabriel, as discussed in the Yom Kippur chapter regarding the coals he took from beneath the Cherub, nor to Elijah, as mentioned in the chapter "HaPoalim" in the case of Rabbi Chiya. It is possible for the two lower ones, Ruach and Nefesh, to descend to the lower Gehenna—not for themselves, but if they happen to have soiled garments due to their poor choices, the garments will burn in the fire while they themselves remain undiminished. But the Neshamah configuration does not need to and is not brought to the lower Gehenna unless it descends there to elevate others, and even this provides it with no small purification for some inferior thought—this explains why thoughts of transgression are more severe than the transgression itself, which is physical while the thoughts are spiritual. 65R 70R 75R 80R

These [thoughts] affect the Neshamah configuration, as the kelipot (negative forces) on its side are few and distant from holiness. In the Ruach configuration, they are half and half, in the mystery of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, but they do not naturally intermingle—rather, each remains separate. This is the secret of Havdalah (separation), that a person should be careful not to mix the holy with the mundane. However, in the Nefesh configuration, even the minority of good is mixed 85R 90R

[i] This refers to a Talmudic story (Hagigah 15a) where the angel Metatron received sixty lashes of fire for sitting down in heaven (which could lead people to think there were two powers in heaven). The chapter 'Ein Dorshin' discusses limitations on teaching mystical subjects.

[ii] This refers to the Talmudic teaching that 'thoughts of sin are more severe than sin itself' (Yoma 29a) because physical sins affect the physical realm while sinful thoughts directly impact the spiritual dimension.

[iii] The concept of 'Havdalah' (separation) is expanded from its liturgical context (the ceremony marking the end of Sabbath) to a mystical principle about maintaining proper spiritual boundaries between holy and mundane.

הטוב מן הרע בכל כחנו וכל
95 אחד מהדיוקנין בלול משלשתן
אלמלא המחשבות הפגומות
ישנן גם באלה השנים עם היותם
משמשים בעצם וראשונה אחד
לדבור ואחד למעשה: [i]

with the majority of evil, and we must separate the good from the evil with all our might. Each of these 95R
configurations includes all three [levels], if not for the flawed thoughts that exist even in these two, despite their being used primarily—one for speech and one for action.

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

מערכה שלישית הצומח
באדם צלם תחתון עבד לפני
המלך[ii] והוא ההתפשטות בעולם
המורגש לתרי תתאי מגו תלתא
5 מן הדיוקנים הנ״ל העליון
שבשנים אלו גם הוא ראש
יחשב לתחתונים וישתנה אקונין
שלישית הלזו לאדם בפני עצמו
ולדוד בפני עצמו ולגואל בפני
10 עצמו וכן לכל דומיהם הכי
נמי לא נשתתפו בו אפי׳ רעים
אהובים. ויש בו תרין דרגין
חד רברבא הנקרא צלם באמת
דכתיב ביה אך בצלם יתהלך איש
15 וחד זעירא הנקרא צל כדכתיב
כצל ימינו עלי ארץ. הראשון
הוא דוגמא שלמה מאקונין

The third arrangement in man is the lower image, a servant before the King,[1] which is the extension into the sensory world of the two lower aspects from within the three configurations mentioned above. The higher of these two is also considered a head 5R
for the lower ones. This third image varies for each individual, such that Adam has his own, David his own, and the Redeemer his own, and similarly for all others like them. Likewise, even beloved friends do not share it. 10R

It contains two levels: one greater, called the true image (tzelem), concerning which it is written, "Surely in an image walks man" (Psalms 39:7), and one lesser, called shadow (tzel),[2] as it is written, "Like a shadow are our days on earth" (1 Chronicles 29:15). 15R The first is a complete representation of the second image we mentioned earlier, while the

[1] This introduces a complex kabbalistic concept describing the third level in the soul's structure. The Hebrew term 'maaracha' (arrangement) reflects the author's systematic approach to mapping the soul's components.

[2] The author distinguishes between two aspects of this soul level using biblical verses: the higher aspect called 'tzelem' (image) and the lower called 'tzel' (shadow). This reflects the kabbalistic practice of finding scriptural bases for mystical concepts.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author cites the Zohar as the primary authority for his understanding of the soul's structure, establishing the text's kabbalistic foundation. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — Mentioned as one of the sources for the author's understanding of human spiritual anatomy, reinforcing the text's engagement with advanced kabbalistic literature. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — Referenced to establish authoritative sources for the text's teachings about soul anatomy, showing the author's deep engagement with esoteric Zoharic literature. | Cf. Pardes Rimmonim by Moses Cordovero — The author specifically references Cordovero's section on the soul, showing his reliance on the systematic Kabbalah of the Safed school as a primary influence. | Cf. Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano — The author identifies Fano as his personal teacher, establishing his own intellectual lineage within Italian Kabbalah, and cites specific works dealing with the microcosmic nature of humans. | Cf. Ein Dorshin chapter of the Talmud — The reference to Metatron receiving sixty lashes of fire connects to the Talmudic warning about the dangers of mystical speculation, suggesting limitations on even angelic beings. | Cf. Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil — Used as a metaphor for the mixed nature of the Ruach level of soul, where good and evil exist in equal measure but remain separate, requiring spiritual discernment.

[ii] The author establishes a hierarchy of soul levels, with this 'third arrangement' described as 'the vegetative in man' and 'the lower image' that serves as a servant before the King. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding of the soul's structure as having multiple levels that mediate between divine and physical realms.

שניה שזכרנו והתחתון גם הוא
יתחלק לשנים שהם לבושי הרוח
והנפש הנזכר באקונין שניה
בסוד חלוקא דרבנן המזומנת
לשלש הדיוקנין בכח פשוט
ששת ימי בראשית אלא שהוא
מחוסר מעשה המצוה וברכותיהן
וכוונתם להשלמתו.[i] וכלן
מסתלקים לנחתמים למיתה
בליל החותם וחוזרים עד שלשים
יום לפני הגויעה[ii] ואז העליון
לבדו שהוא דוגמא מאקונין
שניה הנ״ל הוא לבדו הולך ולא
ישוב עם נשמה עצמה דבריאה
שהיא עולה מאליה לברור את
חלקה ואין נטילתה על ידי שליח
אלא הולכת וחוזרת כפי זכותו
של אדם אך אינה מתיישבת בו
בקביעות והיא חוזרת ג״כ עם
מראה דמות כבוד ה׳ בשעת
סלוק האחרון דכתיב ביה תוסף
רוחם יגועון וכל אלו הל׳ יום
שלפני הגויעה הארת נשמה הזאת
שהיא רושם בעלמא נשארת
בדמיון לפי שהיא כעוטיה בתוך
דיוקן הרוח לבד ובכל לילה
בשהיא עולה לראות וליראות
עם הנשמה עצמה מראין לה
מקום כבודה בההוא עלמא ואין
הרוח העיקרי מלביש לגמרי
ולא מצמצם בעצמו אותו הרושם
הנשאר מן הנשמה שנסתלקה
והלבוש התחתון בשני חלקיו
אינו זז משם עד יום המות
דכתיב ביה עד שיפוח היום

lower one is further divided into two parts: the garments of the ruach and nefesh mentioned in the second image, in the secret of the "scholarly garment" (chaluka d'rabbanan) prepared for the three configurations through simple potential since the six days of creation,[1] though it lacks the fulfillment that comes through performing commandments, their blessings, and the proper intentions to complete it.

All these withdraw from those sealed for death on the night of sealing and return until thirty days before expiration.[2] At that point, only the higher one, which is a representation of the aforementioned second image, departs and does not return, along with the neshamah itself from the World of Creation (Beriah), which ascends on its own to clarify its portion. Its taking is not accomplished through a messenger; rather, it comes and goes according to a person's merit, though it does not settle within him permanently. It also returns with the appearance of the likeness of the glory of the Lord at the time of final departure, concerning which it is written, "You take away their breath, they expire" (Psalms 104:29).

Throughout these thirty days before expiration, the illumination of this neshamah, which is merely an impression, remains as a semblance because it is like a covering within the image of the ruach alone. Each night when it ascends to see and be seen with the neshamah itself, it is shown its place of honor in that world. The essential ruach neither fully clothes nor constrains within itself that impression remaining from the departed neshamah. The lower garment, in its two parts, does not depart until the day of death, concerning which it is written, "Until the day breathes and the shadows flee" (Song of Songs 2:17). The reason is that they rule and actively func-

[1] The 'chaluka d'rabbanan' (scholarly garment) is a kabbalistic concept referring to a spiritual vestment prepared for souls but completed through the performance of commandments. This illustrates how mystical thought viewed human religious actions as completing cosmic processes begun at creation.

[2] The text provides a specific timeline for the soul's gradual departure, beginning with 'the night of sealing' (likely Yom Kippur, when tradition holds that one's fate for the year is sealed) and continuing through a thirty-day process before death.

[i] This refers to the mystical concept of 'chaluka d'rabbanan' (the scholarly garment), a spiritual vestment prepared for the soul since creation but completed through one's performance of commandments, blessings, and proper intentions. This represents how human religious actions create or complete metaphysical structures.

[ii] The text presents a specific timeline for the soul's departure, stating that certain spiritual components begin withdrawing thirty days before death. This provides a mystical explanation for changes that might be observed in a person approaching death.

ונסו הצללים והטעם כי המה
המושלים ופועלים בעצם בשני
55 חלקי הנפש החיונית שנזכר לקמן
לא כן הצלם כי אין לו קרבה
עצמית עם הכחות גופניות רק
בפרוס עליהם סוכת שלום בלבד
וגם בהסתלקו אין איש נגרע מן
60 הפעולות בחיריות והטבעיות
ומכל מחשבות אדם. ומן הצללים
יש לו בבואה ראשונה ושניה כל
ימי חייו לא כן השדים שאין להם
לבוש כי אם מעשיה שבעשיה
65 לבד. והנה השכל הפועל הוא
המלאך הממונה על ההריון הוא
שליח עליון להלביש כללות
התמונה הזאת השלישית בגוף
האדם. וכאן יודיע אליו האל ית׳
70 מהות הצורה שתחול על הטפה
המזדמנת לו באותה שעה החכם
יהיה או סכל והיא הנדונית עם
כל מה שתחתיה בל״ו בריתות
שבתורה כנגד ל״ו מנה דרבוא
75 רבוון דאינון ששים רבוא
אובלסין שהנפש החוטאת נכרתת
מהם ורזא דא מנשמת אלוה
יאבדו ואין צריך לומר צלם
תחתון זה הנזכר למעלה בעצם
80 בגיהנם תחתון לפי צורך המירוק
והיא לבדה נפש המשכלת לבעלי
המחקר. ובה כל הרהורין
ומחשבתין דהבלי עלמא[i] וזו
אינה מסתלקת בשעת השינה
85 כמו שנתבאר. ולהיות שהנשמות
הם חלק אלוה ממעל מצותן
עושות רושם בקדושה העליונה
ושוברות המזל[ii] כמו שבאו הרבה
מעשיות בזה בגמ׳. וכשעולה

tion within the two parts of the vital soul mentioned
below, unlike the image (tzelem), which has no essen-
tial closeness with bodily powers, merely spreading 55R
over them a canopy of peace. Even when it departs,
no one is diminished in terms of willful and natural
functions, nor in any human thoughts.

From the shadows, a person has a primary and
secondary reflection throughout his lifetime, unlike 60R
demons who have no garment except from the low-
est level of the World of Action (Asiyah). The Active
Intellect, which is the angel appointed over concep-
tion, is the supernal messenger that clothes this third
form in its entirety within the human body. Here, 65R
the blessed God informs him about the nature of the
form that will descend upon the droplet prepared for
him at that time—whether he will be wise or fool-
ish. This is judged, along with everything beneath
it, by the thirty-six excisions in the Torah,[1] corre- 70R
sponding to thirty-six portions from the sixty myri-
ads of souls, from which the sinning soul is cut off.
This is the secret of "from the breath of God they
perish" (Job 4:9). It goes without saying that this
lower image mentioned above essentially enters the 75R
lower Gehinnom according to the need for purifica-
tion. This alone is the intellectual soul according to
the philosophers, and it contains all thoughts and
contemplations of worldly vanities. This does not
depart during sleep, as has been explained. 80R

Since souls are a portion of God above, their
commandments leave an impression in the supernal
holiness and break through astrological destiny,[2] as
many accounts in the Talmud demonstrate. When
the soul ascends after its departure, many souls of 85R
the righteous come to greet it, as stated in the hidden
Midrash that after the passing of Rabbi Shimon bar
Yochai, three hundred souls of the righteous came to
him, and above them was Abraham who sat beside

[1] The reference to 'thirty-six excisions' relates to the 36 transgressions in Torah that incur the punishment of 'karet' (spiritual excision), where a soul is cut off from its source. The author correlates this with the structure of souls in the mystical cosmos.

[2] This expresses a fundamental kabbalistic concept that human souls are literally divine fragments and that performing commandments creates metaphysical effects in higher realms that can override astrological determinations.

[i] The text identifies this lower soul level as the seat of worldly thoughts and contemplations, positioning it as an intermediary between pure spiritual consciousness and physical existence. This follows Aristotelian concepts of the 'intellectual soul' integrated into kabbalistic thought.

[ii] This expresses the kabbalistic concept that souls are literally 'a portion of God above' and that performing commandments creates metaphysical effects in higher realms and can override astrological destiny.

הנשמה למעלה אחר פטירתה
באים לקראתה כמה נשמות של
צדיקים[i] כמ״ש במדרש הנעלם
כי אחר פטירתו של רשב״י אתו
לותיה תלת מאה נשמי דצדיקיא
ועילא מנהון א״ה דהוא יתיב
גביה והוא ממלל עמיה וכו׳:
וממעשה דמציעא פרק הפועלים
דאמר ר׳ זירא אמש נ״ל ר״י
בר׳ חנינא אמרתי לו אצל מי
אתה תקוע א״ל אצל ר׳ יוחנן
ור״י אצל מי אצל ר׳ ינאי ור׳
ינאי אצל מי וכו׳ משם התברר
כי החכמים בני ישיבה אחת וכן
התלמידים עם רבם לומדים
יחד בג״ע ויושבים איש כפי
מדרגתו וכבודו[ii] כאומרו באתר
דזקוקין דנור ובעורין דאשא
מאן מעייל בר נפחא לתמן ויש
להם קתדראות באומרם צדיקים
יושבים. נוטלים ויורדים בכח
הארה ההיא הסובבת אותם
בקתדרא מישיבה שלמעלה
להתעדן בצרור החיים ואשרי מי
שזכה לשמש אדם גדול בעוה״ז
כדאמרי׳ מעשה בתלמיד של
ר׳ אליעזר שנתחייב שריפה
למקום ואמרו הניחו לו שאדם
גדול שמש ע״כ אמרו אם דומה
הרב למלאך ה׳ צבאות תורה
יבקשו מפיהו. ובן שם במציעא
נפל פתקא מרקיעא בפומבדיתא
רבה בר נחמני נתבקש בישיבה
של מעלה ונראה ג״כ מה שאמרו
מפורש בפ׳ אלו הן הגולין גבי
ידיו רב לו הנאמר ביהודה וזו
מעלה נפלאה לנשמה ללמוד
תורה בג״ע כמו שהיתה עושה

him and conversed with him. 90R

From the incident in Bava Metzia, chapter "The Workers," where Rabbi Zeira said, "Last night Rabbi Yochanan son of Rabbi Chanina appeared to me. I asked him, 'With whom are you established?' He replied, 'With Rabbi Yochanan.' 'And Rabbi Yochanan with whom?' 'With Rabbi Yannai.' 'And Rabbi Yannai with whom?' etc." From this it becomes clear that scholars of one academy, as well as students with their teacher, study together in the Garden of Eden and sit according to their level and honor,[1] as it states, "In the place of fiery sparks and burning flames, who brings the blacksmith there?" They have chairs, as they say, "The righteous sit." They are taken and descend, through the power of that illumination that surrounds them in the chair from the academy above, to delight in the bond of life. Fortunate is one who merits to serve a great person in this world, as they said, "There was an incident with a student of Rabbi Eliezer who was condemned to burning by Heaven, and they said, 'Leave him be, for he served a great man.'" Therefore they said, "If the teacher resembles an angel of the Lord of Hosts, they should seek Torah from his mouth." Similarly, in Metzia it states that a note fell from heaven in Pumbedita: "Rabbah bar Nachmani has been summoned to the heavenly academy." This is also apparent from what is explicitly stated in the chapter "These Are the Exiles" regarding "his hands are sufficient for him" said about Judah. This is a wonderful privilege for the soul, to study Torah in the Garden of Eden as it did in this world, and fortunate is the one who merits it.

90R 95R 100R 105R 110R 115R 120R

[1] The text uses Talmudic narratives to establish that the hierarchical relationships and learning activities of Torah scholars continue in the afterlife, maintaining the same structure as earthly academies.

[i] The text presents a vivid description of the soul's journey after death, where it is greeted by souls of righteous individuals who have passed away previously. This illustrates the communal nature of the afterlife in Jewish mystical thought.

[ii] This passage establishes that the hierarchical relationships between teachers and students continue in the Garden of Eden, with souls grouped according to their earthly affiliations and continuing their Torah study. This reflects the belief that core spiritual activities continue and are perfected in the afterlife.

בעוה״ז ואשרי הזוכה אליה: [i]

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

המערכה ד׳ הדומה באדם
היא הנפש חיונית שראתה בחוש
ונתקדשה בשעה שאמרה על הים
זה אלי ואהיה לו נוה שהכסא
קרוב מהנוה ונמשיל הכסא
בעצמנו במערכה ג׳ שזכרנו
והלבוש שנדרש במערכה שניה
יותר קרוב מנוה וכסא וזה
על צד ההשאלה. אך איקונין
ראשונה אין להם יחס לא עם
היכל ולא עם כסא ולא עם לבוש
רק חלק ה׳ עמו ולברא הכסא
בשבילם שאור איקונין ראשונה
אינו מתגלה רק בהתלבשותה
בכסא לכן פני יעקב חקוקים
בכסא. וראוי לדעת כי עם
הרכבת היסודות ע״י תנועת
הגרמים השמיימים כדי שיחול
עליה צורה אנושית נראה לעינים
אז מתקדשת הנפש הזאת החיונית
ויצירתה באותה שעה מצד
מה שהיא כח בגוף לא זולת
ויוצאה לפעלה ולעבודתה על
ידי המלאך שזכרנו המהוה
אותה ומציירה בשני בחותיה
הוא הבל״א דגר״מי שהוא החום
הטבעי בסיס לנפש הצומחת אשר

The fourth arrangement in man is the vital soul that perceived with the senses and was sanctified at the moment when it declared at the sea, “This is my God,” and I will be a dwelling place for Him,[A] for the throne is closer than the dwelling, and we can compare the throne to ourselves in the third arrangement we mentioned, and the garment discussed in the second arrangement is closer than the dwelling and throne, though this is metaphorical. However, the first image has no relationship with palace, throne, or garment—it is solely “the portion of the Lord is His people,” and the throne was created for them, since the light of the first image is only revealed when clothed in the throne; therefore, Jacob’s face is engraved on the throne. It is important to understand that with the composition of elements through the movement of celestial bodies, so that a human form visible to the eyes may rest upon it, this vital soul becomes sanctified, and its formation at that moment derives from its being a power in the body, nothing else, and it emerges to its function and service through the angel we mentioned who brings it into being and forms it with its two powers. The first is the “breath of the bones,”[B] which is the natural heat that serves as the foundation for the vegetative soul, about which it is decreed whether one will be rich or poor, and this is the animal soul, whose af-

[A] Or: “and He shall be my dwelling place” — The Hebrew can be interpreted either as the soul becoming a dwelling for God or as God becoming a dwelling for the soul. The second interpretation aligns with the mystical concept of divine protection.

[B] Or: “the vapor of the bones” — The term refers to a subtle spiritual essence that remains in the bones even after death. ‘Vapor’ might better capture the ephemeral quality of this essence than ‘breath’.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The passage adopts the Zohar’s multi-layered conception of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) and its teachings about how souls continue their existence after death, particularly the concept that righteous souls gather together in heavenly academies. | Cf. Psalms 39:7 — The author cites this verse to establish the biblical basis for the kabbalistic concept of tzelem (divine image) as an aspect of human spiritual structure. | Cf. 1 Chronicles 29:15 — This verse is used to establish the concept of tzel (shadow) as the lesser aspect of the divine image in humans, emphasizing the transient nature of physical existence. | Cf. Song of Songs 2:17 — The author interprets this poetic verse in a kabbalistic context to refer to the departure of the lower aspects of the soul at death. | Cf. Job 4:9 — This verse is linked to the kabbalistic concept of kareit (spiritual excision), where a soul is cut off from its divine source. | Cf. Talmud Bava Metzia — The author uses this Talmudic story to demonstrate how souls maintain their hierarchical relationships and continue Torah study in the afterlife. | Cf. Midrash Hane’elam (Hidden Midrash) — This reference from the ‘Hidden Midrash’ (likely a section of the Zohar) is used to illustrate how righteous souls are greeted by other souls, including biblical figures, after death.

נגזר עליה עשיר או עני והיא
הנפש הבהמו״ת שעסקיה רעים
בדברים בטלים למי שנגרר
אחריהם. החכמה תעוז לחכם
למשול בה עד רדתה להיות
חיות קצת לגופות הצדיקים
אשר שוכבים בקברם שהמה
לשלמותם שאין בלבם קנאה
מתקדשים ומתטהרים בה ואין
עצמותיהם מרקיבים והב׳
עצבונ״א דבשר״א היא נפש
המרגשת דאתמר עליה גבור או
חלש והיא רוח ממללא בהבלי
עלמא ורמה קשה לה בקבר
כמחט בבשר החי עד שיתעכל
הבשר. אך צדיקים יודו לשמו
יתברך וכתיב בהו אף בשרי
ישכון לבטח כי הם ישני אדמת
עפר ערבה שנתם בלי מונע כי
אין לרימה חלק ונחלה כלל
בבשרם ועצמותיהם יחליץ ויציל
שופט צדק מהתכת הרכבתם עד
שעה אחת קודם תחיית המתים
לקיים בהם ואל עפר תשוב[i] כי
הכל היה מן העפר ואפי׳ גלגל
חמה.[ii] ועתידים צדיקים שיהיו
פניהם דומים לחמה. וישנה ג״כ
לזאת הצורה החיונית לכל אחד
מאישי המין לא ישתתף בה זולתו
אם לא על צד העבור כנדרש
בשניה ובשלישית וכל מיתה שאין
בה כרת בין בדיני אדם בין
בדיני שמים משפטם אבדן הנפש
החיונית בלבד ויש בדיני אדם
ל״ו גופי עבירות להתחייב בהם
מיתת ב״ד שמונה עשר בנסקלין

fairs are concerned with worthless matters for those
who are drawn after them. “Wisdom strengthens
the wise” to rule over it until it descends to become
some vitality for the bodies of the righteous who lie
in their graves, who, in their perfection, having no
jealousy in their hearts, are sanctified and purified
through it, and their bones do not decay. The sec-
ond power is the “distress of the flesh,”[A] which is the
sensing soul, of which it is said one is either strong
or weak, and it is the speaking spirit concerned with
worldly vanities, and the worm is as painful to it in
the grave as a needle in living flesh until the flesh
decomposes. But the righteous give thanks to His
blessed name, and it is written of them, “Even my
flesh shall dwell securely,” for they are sleepers in the
dust of the pleasant earth,[1] their sleep unimpeded,
for the worm has no portion or inheritance at all in
their flesh, and the righteous Judge will strengthen
and save their bones from the dissolution of their
composition until one hour before the resurrection
of the dead, to fulfill in them “and to dust you shall
return,” for everything was from dust, even the orb of
the sun. And the righteous are destined to have faces
resembling the sun. This vital form is also unique to
each individual of the species; no one else shares in
it except through the process of soul impregnation,
as explained in the second and third arrangements.
Every death that does not involve spiritual excision,
whether by human law or divine law, results only in
the loss of the vital soul. In human law, there are
thirty-six major transgressions punishable by court-
imposed deat[2]h: eighteen by stoning, ten by burning,
two by beheading, and six by strangulation, which
correspond to the thirty-six measures of the myriad
of myriads we mentioned, each according to its way.
The power of the court was effective, for all those li-

30R 35R 40R 45R 50R 55R 60R

[A] Or: “the sadness of the flesh” — This term describes the suffering or heaviness associated with physicality. ‘Sadness’ could be more appropriate as it implies an emotional quality rather than just physical pain.

[1] The author is creating a contrast between ordinary death, where decomposition is painful to the soul, and the death of the righteous, which is portrayed as a peaceful sleep without suffering.
[2] The author refers to the four methods of capital punishment in Jewish law (stoning, burning, beheading, and strangulation) and suggests that these judicial punishments had the spiritual effect of preventing the more severe divine punishment of spiritual excision (karet).

[i] A reference to Genesis 3:19, ‘for dust you are and to dust you will return.’ The author is noting that even the righteous must fulfill this decree, but only at the last moment before resurrection.
[ii] The orb or sphere of the sun. In medieval cosmology, even celestial bodies were believed to be composed of refined elements that would return to their source at the end of time.

עשר בנשרפין שתים בנהרגין
ושש בנחנקין אשר יש להם אותו
היחס עם ל״ו מנה דרבוא רבוון
שזכרנו האי כי אורחיה והאי
כי אורחיה. ויפה היה כח ב״ד
שכל חייבי כריתות שלקו וכ״ש
שהיו מומתים על ידם נפטרו
מידי כריתתן שאין הצלם שלהם
נגעל. וגם הנפש החיונית הלזו
יורדת שחת להשלמת המירוק.
והסבוב שיש בו חילוף אי אפשר
בשום פנים שיתואר זולתי לשתי
מערכות התחתונות יחד או
לאחרונה שבהם כפי חומר׳ העון
אם בסוד המאסר או באבדן
הצורה הראשונה. אלה איפה
הם ד׳ מערכות כוללות לכל
חלקי הנפש כלליהן ופרטיהן
בדקדוק וכבר יצדק בהם על
צד אחד מצדי ההשאלה אשר
יאמר לתחתונה נפש בסוד ה״א
אחרונה של שם. שניה לה רוח
והיא עצמה וא״ו נשמה על גביהן
ה״א ראשונה אך מערכה גדולה
שזכרנו ראשונה היא נשמתא
לנשמתא יו״ד שבשם. והזוכים
בארבע מערכות אלה כפי
המכוון בהם ליוצר בראשית הוא
יחידו של עולם הנרמז בקוצו
של יו״ד[i] המה הקוצרים בשדה
אשר ברכו ה׳ מחצד״י חקל״א
קדישא[ii] ודאי והמלה הנכבדת

able to excision who were flogged, and certainly those
executed by them, were exempted from their excision, as their image was not defiled. This vital soul
also descends to the pit to complete its purification.
The cycle involving transmigration cannot possibly
be attributed to any but the two lowest arrangements
together, or to the last of them, according to the
gravity of the sin, whether through imprisonment or
the loss of the original form. These, then, are the
four comprehensive arrangements for all parts of the
soul, their general and specific aspects in detail, and
they can rightly be described metaphorically, calling
the lowest "nefesh"[1] corresponding to the final hei of
the divine Name, the second "ruach" corresponding
to the vav, "neshamah" above them corresponding
to the first hei, but the great arrangement we mentioned first is the "soul of the soul" corresponding to
the yod of the Name. Those who merit these four
arrangements according to the Creator's intention—
the Unique One of the universe hinted at in the point
of the yod—are the reapers in the field blessed by the
Lord, truly "reapers of the holy field,"[A] and this honored expression is an acronym for the entire subject:
"speaker, living, growing, inanimate," which, with
the inclusive number, equals in gematria "Tzeva'ot"
(Hosts), and it is said of them, "The Lord is with
you," with His four letters, a full name called upon
a full world, and for this reason the complete person
is called a "small world," and this is what we have
learned: "Whoever engages in Torah for its own sake
is worthy of the entire world."[2] Happy is the people
that has it so.[3]

[A] Or: "harvesters of the holy field" — While 'reapers' is accurate, 'harvesters' might better convey the kabbalistic concept of gathering divine sparks, which is likely the intended meaning here.

[1] The author is presenting the kabbalistic correspondence between the four levels of the soul and the four letters of the divine name YHVH (the Tetragrammaton), a fundamental concept in Jewish mysticism.

[2] This is a quotation from Pirkei Avot (Ethics of the Fathers) 6:1, used here to reinforce the connection between Torah study and achieving the complete soul structure that makes one a 'small world' reflecting the entire cosmos.

[3] This is a quotation from Psalms 144:15 that concludes this section on the soul's arrangement, suggesting that those who understand and cultivate the proper soul structure achieve a blessed state.

[i] This is a reference to the kabbalistic concept that the point (or crown) of the letter yod in the divine name represents the highest level of divinity—Keter or even Ein Sof (the Infinite).

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means 'reapers of the holy field' and appears in the Zohar. It refers to those who gather divine sparks or spiritual insights, often associated with the souls of the righteous or those who study mystical wisdom.

הזאת נוטריקון לכלל הדרוש
מ״דבר ח״י צ״ומח ד״ומם[i] שהם
עם הכולל בגימטריא צבא״ות
ואתמר בהו ה׳ עמכם בארבע
אותיות דיליה שם מלא נקרא
על עולם מלא ומזה הטעם יקרא
האדם השלם עול״ם קט״ן והיינו
דתנינן כל העוסק בתורה לשמה
כל העולם כלו כדאי הוא לו.
אשרי העם שככה לו:[ii]

פרק ה׳

עוד לנו לדעת כי בזולת
שנשמת האדם בכלל כלולה
מי׳ ספירות עוד היא כלולה
מד׳ יסודות עליונים כנוף
שכלול מד׳ יסודות תחתונים.
וד׳ יסודות של אצילות נודע
שהם גנת״מ[iii] ומלבוש שאמרנו
שהוא בבריאה יהיו יסודותיו
ד׳ עמודי כסא שהם לד׳
רוחות העולם אדנ״י למזרח.
אל לדרום. אלהים לצפון
ולמערב.[iv] ואופן אחד משתרבב
משם לארץ דלא ישארון תתאין

Chapter 5

We should further understand that beyond the soul of man being generally comprised of the ten sefirot,[1] it is also composed of four supernal elements, just as the body is composed of four lower elements. The four elements of Atzilut (Emanation) are known to be Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, and Malkhut. The garment that we mentioned exists in Beriah (Creation) has as its elements the four pillars of the Throne, which correspond to the four directions of the world: Adonai to the east, El to the south, and Elohim to the north and west. And one Ofan (angelic wheel) extends from there to earth so that the lower beings will not remain

[1] The author is establishing a complex spiritual anatomy where the soul has both a general structure (reflecting the ten sefirot) and elements corresponding to the four kabbalistic worlds, mirroring how the physical body is composed of four terrestrial elements.

[i] These are the four kingdoms of existence in kabbalistic thought: medaber (speaking/human), chai (living/animal), tzomeach (growing/vegetative), and domem (silent/mineral). The human soul contains elements corresponding to all these levels.

[ii] Cf. Zohar I, 218a — This passage draws directly on Zoharic teachings about the soul's structure and its correspondence to the divine name YHVH, with each letter representing a different soul level | Cf. Exodus 15:2 — The author connects the soul's sanctification to the revelatory moment at the splitting of the sea, when Israel declared 'This is my God'—suggesting that the vital soul has direct experiential knowledge of divinity | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:19 — Used to support the idea that wisdom enables control over the animal soul's tendency toward material concerns | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author invokes the concept of 'olam katan' (small world) to suggest that the complete human being who has properly organized all soul levels mirrors the structure of the entire cosmos | Cf. Psalms 16:9 — Used to support the kabbalistic idea that the righteous experience bodily preservation and peaceful rest even after death

[iii] The abbreviation גנת״מ stands for גבורה, גדולה (חסד), תפארת, מלכות—the four sefirot Gevurah, Gedulah (Chesed), Tiferet, and Malkhut, which are considered the four elements of the World of Emanation.

[iv] This presents a directional correspondence of divine names with the four directions: the name Adonai with east, El with south, and Elohim with both north and west, reflecting the kabbalistic understanding of how divine forces flow into our world through these cardinal points.

בלא אשגחותא.[i] עיין בזוהר שיר
15 השירים מזה. ובמלבוש היצירה
יהיו ד׳ פני החיות. ובמלבוש
העשיה רוחניות יהיו יסודותיו
ממראה האופנים הנכללים
באופן אחד בארץ לארבעת פניו.
20 ועוד כתיב ומראיהם ומעשיהם
כאשר יהיה האופן בתוך האופן.
ומכאן יהיו יסודות הצלם שזכר
המלך החסיד והצללים שנים
שזכרם החכם בנו בשיר השירים
25 ובמלבוש הגלגלים שמהם כח
הנפש החיונית הגנוזה בבי קברי.
ואולי עליה אמרו בפ׳ אלו
מגלחין כשקם חזקיה בריה דרב
חייא מקבריה לחלוק כבוד לרב
30 הונא קם בהדיה עמודא דנורא
ואסתכן ר׳ חגי. וחלקי נפש
הזאת הבלא דגרמי ועצבונא
דבשרא[ii] יהיו יסודותיו מהגשם
החמישי אם שיהיה הוא מבחר
35 היסודות התחתונים. או מהות
גשמי נכבד מאד עומד בפני
עצמו זולתם אשר לא הוכר
מהפלוסופים. ולעולם הנשמה
כלולה מי׳ אלא שמלבד זה היו
40 גוברים ומתגלים בה ד׳ יסודות
הנזכרים על דרך שיתראו בה
ד׳ פנים אלו מאירים בה יותר
משאר העשר. וכבר אמרנו
למעלה כי אחר הפטירה תשאר
45 הנפש בעה״ז בקבר. וברוחניות
העשיה יש מקום ידוע הנקרא

without divine supervision.[1] See the Zohar on Song
of Songs regarding this. In the garment of Yetzirah 15R
(Formation), there are the four faces of the Chayot
(living creatures). And in the spiritual garment
of Asiyah (Action), its elements are from the
appearance of the Ofanim (wheels) that are included
in one wheel on earth with its four faces. And 20R
furthermore it is written, “And their appearance
and their work was as it were a wheel within a
wheel.” From here derive the elements of the Tzelem
(divine image) mentioned by the pious king, and the
two shadows mentioned by his wise son in Song of 25R
Songs, and in the garment of the celestial spheres
from which comes the power of the vital soul that is
hidden in the graves. Perhaps regarding this they
said in the chapter “These May Shave” that when
Hezekiah son of Rabbi Chiyya rose from his grave 30R
to pay respect to Rav Huna, a pillar of fire rose
with him and Rabbi Chagai was endangered.[2] And
the components of this soul—the breath of the
bones and the distress of the flesh—have as their
elements the fifth substance, if it is indeed the 35R
choicest of the lower elements, or perhaps a most
honored physical essence standing independently
apart from them, which was not recognized by the
philosophers.[3] And always the soul includes the
ten [sefirot], but beyond this, the four elements 40R
mentioned above predominate and are revealed in
it, in such a way that these four aspects shine within
it more than the other ten. And we have already
stated above that after death, the nefesh remains
in this world in the grave. And in the spirituality 45R
of Asiyah, there is a known place also called “the

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that there must be continuous connection between higher and lower worlds. The Ofan (a class of angels described in Ezekiel’s vision) serves as a conduit of divine providence, ensuring that even the lowest spiritual realms remain connected to divine guidance.

[2] This Talmudic story illustrates how even after death, great sages retain their spiritual power. The pillar of fire represents the intense spiritual energy that remained with Rabbi Hezekiah even in death, so powerful that it posed danger to the living Rabbi Chagai.

[3] The author suggests that the fifth element constituting the vital soul might not be the quintessence (ether) recognized by Aristotelian philosophy, but something entirely different that philosophers failed to identify—showing how Jewish mysticism sometimes positions itself as possessing knowledge beyond Greek philosophical traditions.

[i] Aramaic phrase meaning “so that the lower beings will not remain without divine supervision,” reflecting the kabbalistic principle that there must be continuous connection between higher and lower worlds for divine providence to operate.

[ii] These Aramaic terms refer to two components of the vital soul: “havla d’garmi” (breath/vapor of the bones) and “atzvona d’bishra” (distress/sadness of the flesh), representing how the soul animates the body’s skeletal structure and flesh respectively.

גם הוא בי קברי וחצר מות.
ושם תנוח נפש דעשיה. ולא
תשאר בקבר ממש התחתון זולתי
הנפש החיונית שהיא מהגלגלים.
והרוח דיצירה מנוחתה בג״ע של
מטה. והנשמה דבריאה שוכבת
ומנוחתה בפרגוד והוא גן עליון
לפנים מן הפרגוד האמצעי תחת
כסא הכבוד והרוחות שהיו
מספרות זו עם זו מה ששמעו
מאחורי הפרגוד דמס׳ ברכות
הם שני אחורים לפרגוד ההוא
א׳ מיצירה וא׳ מעשיה. ונשמות
הצרורות בצרור החיים אינן
מתלבשים בשום מלבוש אוירי כי
אם לעתים ידועים. כרבי בעת
שהיה אומר קידוש גם שבמתים
חפשי מן המצות אז היה כחי
לכל דבריו ולא נקרא מוציא
שם שמים לבטלה וכן ר׳ יוסי
הגלילי היה בא לביתו בכל ערב
שבת ושני תלמידים עברו ושמעו
קולו שהיה שונה בתורה. וכתוב
ביוחסין דף קל״ב ע״ב כי רבינו
יחיאל אביו של הרא״ש הר׳
יהודה בן אשר נינו העיד עליו
בצוואתו ששחק בארונו לפני
כל הקהל כששאל ממנו חברו
החכם שיקיים שבועתו שיחלקו
בעה״ב והניע ראשו ושחק.
ואמרו שבא לביתו ולבית מדרשו
אחר פטירתו כרבינו הקדוש
ע״כ. ויעקב אבינו שאמרו
עליו שלא מת נשמתו אינה
נשארת ערומה מהלבוש אפי׳
שעה אחת אלא נשמתו בצרור
החיים ובלבוש אצלה תמיד
מזומן וחופף וכל זמן שנשמתו
רוצה להתלבש בו מתלבשת
וכשישראל בצער הגלות נשמת
יעקב לובשת המלבוש כי יכול

house of graves" and "the court of death." There the nefesh of Asiyah rests. Only the vital soul, which is from the celestial spheres, actually remains in the lower grave.[1] The ruach of Yetzirah rests in the lower Garden of Eden. And the neshamah of Beriah lies and rests in the Pargod (celestial curtain), which is the upper Garden beyond the middle Pargod beneath the Throne of Glory. The spirits that were conversing with each other about what they heard from behind the Pargod mentioned in Tractate Berakhot are two "backs" to that Pargod—one from Yetzirah and one from Asiyah. The souls that are bound in the bundle of life do not clothe themselves in any ethereal garment except at specific times. For example, Rabbi [Judah the Prince], when he would recite Kiddush—even though "the dead are free from the commandments"—at that time he was powerful in all his words and was not considered as one who utters the divine name in vain.[2] Similarly, Rabbi Yosi the Galilean would come to his home every Sabbath eve, and two disciples passed by and heard his voice as he was studying Torah. And it is written in Yuhasin page 132b that our teacher Yechiel, the father of the Rosh, Rabbi Yehudah ben Asher, his great-grandson, testified about him in his will that he laughed in his coffin before the entire congregation when his wise colleague asked him to fulfill his oath that they would share in the World to Come, and he nodded his head and laughed. And they said that he came to his house and study hall after his death, like our holy Rabbi [Judah the Prince]. And our father Jacob, about whom they said that he did not die—his soul does not remain naked without a garment even for a single hour. Rather, his soul is in the bundle of life, and a garment is always prepared and hovering near it. Whenever his soul wishes to clothe itself in it, it does so. And when Israel is in the distress of exile, Jacob's soul dons the garment, for it can appear like Elijah, and it seeks mercy through the power of its prayer, drawing the power of mercy to

50R 55R 60R 65R 70R 75R 80R 85R

[1] The text presents a detailed cosmology of where different soul components reside after death. The lowest soul component (nefesh) associated with the World of Action (Asiyah) remains in a spiritual version of the grave, while only the animating life-force stays with the physical remains.

[2] This passage addresses the theological problem of how deceased sages could perform rituals that include divine names when the dead are generally exempt from commandments. The author explains that at these special moments, the soul temporarily regains its power to fulfill religious obligations without transgressing the prohibition against vain utterance of God's name.

להתראות באליהו ומבקשת
רחמים בכח תפלתה ממשכת
כח הרחמים לבניו ואח״כ שבה
אל צרור החיים בלי לבוש כי
א״א לנשמה להתפלל ולהמשיך
שפע לתחתונים אלא בלבוש זה.
והנשמה שהיא מאצילות תתעלה
לשרשים העליונים. ולפעמים גם
הנפש והרוח והנשמה דבריאה
ויצירה עשיה תתקשרנה זו בזו
ותעלה שם כי מאחר שהם נצוצות
מתפשטים מהאור העליון לכן
בשיהיו העולמות מתיחדים
יתיחדו הענפים בשרשים כמו
שיזדקקו ויתיחדו התיכלות
ויתעלו אל שרשם העליון בסוד
התפלה כן הדבר בנפש רוח
ונשמה כי העשיה תתיחד ביצירה
והיצירה בבריאה והבריאה
באצילות והאצילות בנקודה
העליונה. ולא הכל זוכים אל
הרוח אפי׳ דיצירה כ״ש נשמה
דבריאה. וכבר אמרנו בחלק
ראשון כי יש עוד תוספת נשמה
מאצילות לעתים בעסקו במצוה
ובשבתות וימים טובים. והזוכה
בחול לקבל נשמה מצד אצילות
מבינה יתוסף בו בשבתות וימים
טובים נשמה יתירה מצד הכתר.
כי תעלה נשמתו שתי מדרגות
אחד למדת לילה ואחד למדת
יום. ולרוב בני האדם בימי
החול הוא יונק ומתלבש בנשמה
מסטרא דיצירה ובריאה עבד
ואמה והוא במדרגת עבד דכתיב

his children.[1] Afterward, it returns to the bundle of
life without a garment, for it is impossible for a soul
to pray and draw divine flow to those below except 90R
through this garment. The soul that is from Atzilut
ascends to the supernal roots. And sometimes the
nefesh, ruach, and neshamah of Beriah, Yetzirah,
and Asiyah bind together and ascend there, because
they are sparks extending from the supernal light. 95R
Therefore, when the worlds unite, the branches
unite with the roots, just as the palaces are refined
and unite and ascend to their supernal root through
the mystery of prayer. So it is with nefesh, ruach,
and neshamah—for Asiyah unites with Yetzirah, 100R
and Yetzirah with Beriah, and Beriah with Atzilut,
and Atzilut with the supernal point.[2] Not everyone
merits the ruach, even of Yetzirah, and certainly
not the neshamah of Beriah. We have already said
in the first part that there is an additional soul from 105R
Atzilut at times when one is engaged in a mitzvah
and on Sabbaths and festivals. One who merits
on weekdays to receive a soul from the aspect of
Atzilut, from Binah, will have an additional soul
from the aspect of Keter added to him on Sabbaths 110R
and festivals. For his soul rises two levels—one to
the attribute of night and one to the attribute of
day.[3] For most people on weekdays, they draw from
and clothe themselves in a soul from the aspect of
Yetzirah and Beriah, servant and maidservant, and 115R
one is at the level of a servant, as it is written: "Six
days shall you labor." But on Sabbaths, when one
is clothed in an additional soul from the aspect of
Atzilut, it is said of him: "you shall rest," because
he is a king, a free person, and is then called 120R
"son" rather than "servant" as on weekdays.[4] And
we have already explained in the section "Lips of

[1] This presents the mystical understanding that the biblical patriarchs, particularly Jacob, continue to intercede for their descendants during times of hardship. This concept of ancestral intercession is significant in Jewish mysticism and offers theological comfort during persecution by suggesting that the spiritual founders of the nation remain actively engaged in its welfare.

[2] This describes the process of spiritual ascension and unification where each lower world progressively unites with the one above it, ultimately connecting to the highest divine source (the "supernal point"). This mystical unification reflects the kabbalistic goal of restoring cosmic harmony through spiritual practice.

[3] The attributes of night and day likely refer to the sefirot of Malkhut (associated with night, feminine divine aspect) and Tiferet (associated with day, masculine divine aspect), suggesting that the soul's elevation on Sabbath allows it to harmonize and transcend these complementary divine forces.

[4] This passage reveals a profound mystical understanding of the Sabbath as transforming one's spiritual status and relationship with the Divine. The transition from "servant" to "son" represents a shift from the distant relationship of master-servant to the intimate connection of parent-child, reflecting the deeper union with God made possible through Sabbath observance.

ששת ימים תעבוד. אבל בשבתות
שיתלבש בתוספת נשמה מצד
125 האצילות נאמר בו תשבות מפני
שהוא מלך בן חורין ונקרא אז
בן, ובחול עבד.[i] וכבר בארנו
בחלק שפתי צדק מציאות ב׳
מלאכים שהם יצ״ט ויצה״ר
130 ומרכבתם זה רוכב בטמאה ויצר
טוב בטהורה ושניהם קדושים
מתחלת יצירתם ועליהם נאמר
כי מלאכיו יצוה לך לשמרך בכל
דרכיך:[ii]

Righteousness" the existence of two angels, which are the good inclination and the evil inclination, and their vehicles—one rides in impurity and the 125R
good inclination in purity—and both are holy from the beginning of their formation, and of them it is said: "For He will command His angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways."

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

אחר שמפי סופרים וספרים
העלינו בפרקים הקודמים קצת
ממהות חלקי נשמת האדם הדרן
למאן דפתחנא ביה בפ״ק מחלק

After having drawn from the mouths of scribes and books[1] in previous chapters some understanding of the nature of the parts of the human soul, we return to what we began in the first chapter of

[1]The Hebrew phrase 'מפי סופרים וספרים' (from the mouths of scribes and books) is a formulaic expression referring to both oral and written scholarly traditions, similar to the rabbinic phrase 'מפי ספרים ומפי סופרים' (from books and from scribes).

[i]This passage presents a profound spiritual understanding of the Sabbath, where one's spiritual status is elevated from servant (weekdays) to son (Sabbath). The transformation occurs through the neshamah yeteirah (additional soul) that derives from the highest world of Atzilut, changing one's relationship with the Divine from servitude to kinship.

[ii]Cf. Zohar on Song of Songs — This reference demonstrates the author's reliance on the Zohar as an authoritative mystical source for his cosmological framework that connects the higher and lower worlds through angelic intermediaries. | Cf. Tractate Berakhot — This reference connects Talmudic narrative to the kabbalistic cosmology being described, showing how the author integrates rabbinic and mystical traditions to support his descriptions of the soul's posthumous journey. | Cf. Rabbi Judah the Prince reciting Kiddush after death — This well-known rabbinic story is used to illustrate the author's claim that souls can temporarily clothe themselves in ethereal garments at specific times to perform certain actions in the physical world. | Cf. Rabbi Yosi the Galilean returning on Sabbath eve — This story further supports the author's theological point about righteous souls being able to manifest temporarily in the physical world, particularly on spiritually significant occasions like the Sabbath. | Cf. Sefer Yuhasin — This citation from a historical source provides a more recent example of the phenomenon being discussed, showing the author's effort to demonstrate continuity of these mystical occurrences from ancient to medieval times. | Cf. Jacob did not die — The author uses this rabbinic tradition about Jacob to illustrate his highest level of soul description—one that never loses its spiritual 'clothing' and can therefore intercede for Israel during times of exile, showing the ongoing spiritual agency of the patriarchs. | Cf. Elijah's appearances — This comparison connects Jacob's spiritual status to that of Elijah, who never died but was taken up in a fiery chariot, suggesting a special category of souls that maintain continuous ability to manifest in the physical realm. | Cf. Four worlds of Kabbalah (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) — The author uses the standard kabbalistic framework of four worlds as the organizing principle for explaining the soul's composition, posthumous journey, and spiritual elevation, showing his firm grounding in this mystical tradition. | Cf. Lips of Righteousness (Siftei Tzedek) — This self-reference shows how the author builds on concepts developed earlier in his work, creating internal coherence across the different sections of Ma'avar Yabok, and helping the reader connect related discussions. | Cf. Psalm 91:11 — This biblical reference is reinterpreted through a kabbalistic lens to support the author's teaching about the dual angelic influences (good and evil inclinations) that accompany each person, showing how scriptural texts are incorporated into mystical teachings.

זה כי הנה בחיי האדם יתקשרו
נשמה רוח נפש ונפש המרגשת
שהיא הבהמית שזכרנו למעלה
שבה ה׳ חושים וגוף האדם שבו
הבלא דגרמי ועצבונא דבשרא
ומתייחדים בו מלמעלה למטה.
אמנם אחר המות שהיא החפשיות
מן העבודה במתים חפשי ועבד
חפשי מאדוניו ואין דביקות
החלקים האלה כלפי מטה אל
הגוף כמו בחייו אלא כלפי
מעלה שהנפש נקשרת ברוח ורוח
בנשמה כדדרשו בזהר פ׳ ויחי
והחלקים האלה נפרדים זה מזה
כי אחר המות משכן הנפש בעה״ז
על הקבר[i] על הדרך שבארנו
בפ׳ הקודם וכן ב׳ בחות
הנקראים הבלא דגרמי ועצבונא
דבשרא ויש אויר למעלה מבית
הקברות שהוא קבר עליון
הנקרא חצר מות והוא מדור
הנפשות ומשכן הרוח בג״ע של
מטה ורב חמאי גאון קרא מדור
הזה חדרי ג״ע[ii] והנשמה בג״ע
של מעלה כדפי׳ בזהר פ׳ הנזכר
ובמדרש הנעלם פ׳ תולדות
יצחק ויתקשרו לעתים כגון
בראש חדש ויום טוב ושבתות

this section. For behold, during a person's lifetime, 5R
the neshamah, ruach, nefesh, and the sensing nefesh[1] (which is the animal soul we mentioned above, containing the five senses), as well as the physical body—which contains the breath of the bones (havla d'garmi) and the distress of the flesh 10R
(atzvona d'bishrah)[A]—are all united from above to below. However, after death, which is freedom from service—"among the dead, free" and "a servant is free from his master"[2]—these components are no longer bound downward toward the body as they 15R
were during life, but rather upward,[B] with the nefesh binding to the ruach, and the ruach to the neshamah, as expounded in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi.

These components separate from one another, for 20R
after death, the dwelling place of the nefesh is in this world, above the grave, as we explained in the previous chapter, along with the two powers called "breath of the bones" and "distress of the flesh." There is an atmosphere above the cemetery which is 25R
the upper grave called "Court of Death,"[C] which is the dwelling place of the nefeshes. The dwelling place of the ruach is in the lower Garden of Eden, and Rav Chamai Gaon called this dwelling "the chambers of the Garden of Eden." The neshamah is in the upper 30R
Garden of Eden, as explained in the aforementioned section of the Zohar and in the Hidden Midrash in

[A] Or: "vital essence of the skeleton and the pain sensation of the flesh" — This alternate translation uses more contemporary physiological terminology while attempting to capture the meaning of these mystical concepts. It might be preferred for readers seeking a more scientific-sounding interpretation, though it loses some of the original Aramaic mystical terminology.

[B] Or: "these components no longer maintain their downward orientation toward the body as in life, but instead are oriented upward" — This alternate translation emphasizes the directional orientation rather than the binding quality, which might better convey the spatial metaphor being used to describe the soul's reorientation after death.

[C] Or: "Courtyard of Death" — The Hebrew term חצר more precisely means 'courtyard' or 'enclosure' rather than 'court' (in the sense of a royal court or judicial body). This translation might be preferred for greater architectural precision in the spatial metaphor.

[1] These terms represent the hierarchical structure of the soul in Kabbalah. Neshamah is the highest divine aspect, ruach is the intermediate emotional aspect, nefesh is the basic vital soul, and 'sensing nefesh' refers to the animating force that enables physical sensation.

[2] These are biblical quotations: the first from Psalms 88:6 ('among the dead, free') and the second from Job 3:19 ('a servant is free from his master'), both referring to death as a form of liberation.

[i] This establishes a key concept in Ma'avar Yabok's cosmology: the nefesh (vital soul) remains near the physical grave after death, unlike the higher soul components which ascend to spiritual realms.

[ii] Rav Chamai Gaon was a prominent 9th century Babylonian scholar. His description of the ruach's dwelling place as 'chambers of the Garden of Eden' demonstrates how the author integrates earlier rabbinic opinions into his kabbalistic framework.

אך לא בקשר הקודם.[i] ואולי
בזה נבין קצת טעם למנהג שאין
עושים קשרים בתכריכי המתים
וכן באבנטו שמלבד כי מורה
בטחון התחיה כדאמרי׳ בגמרא
ובירו׳ בצוואות חכמים רבים
באופן לבישתם והעמדתם אחר
מיתתם ג״כ ירמוז כי אין קשר
לנר״נ יחד מתמיד רק עד זמן
התחיה[ii] דאז נשמתא אתוספא
אורה גו אספקלריאה דנהרא
לאתנהרא גופא לקיומא שלים
בדקא חזי. ומהקשר הזה המועט
יש עדון לגוף שעקרו הם החמשה
חושים הדבקים בעצם שתחת מוח
האדם בפנימיות הגלגולת ואינו
דבק בו אלא עצם אחד והוא
קטן כשעורה אמנם הוא עגול
קרוב אל המרובע ובו חוטי דם
כדמות קורי עכביש מסובבים
אלו באלו[iii] ובאותם הורידים
מיוסדים ה׳ חושים זהו דעת
החכם קורדואיר״ו במציאות
עצם הנזכר וכן הביא בעל צרור
המור בשם הרמב״ם ז״ל הגם
שמדברי רבים נראה שהוא עצם
לוז שבסוף שדרתו של אדם
דכרע במודים בכל ח״י חוליות
שבשדרה והעצם הזה חי לעולם
כדאמרי׳ במדרש ובקהלת רבתי
שנבקע הסדן ואש אינו יכול
לשרפו ולבן הוא חי סמוך לחי.
ובפ׳ ויקרא רבה פ׳ י״ח מעשה

Parashat Toldot Yitzchak. They reconnect at certain times, such as on the New Moon, festivals, and Sabbaths, but not with the same bond as before.

Perhaps through this we can understand somewhat the reason for the custom of not making knots in the shrouds of the dead, nor in the belt. Beyond showing confidence in the resurrection, as mentioned in the Talmud and in the Jerusalem Talmud in the testaments of many sages regarding the manner of their dressing and positioning after death, it also alludes to the fact that there is no permanent bond holding the nefesh-ruach-neshamah together, only until the time of resurrection, when "the neshamah will receive additional light through the illuminating lens[A] to illuminate the body for complete and proper existence."

From this minimal connection, there is pleasure for the body, whose essence consists of the five senses that adhere to the bone beneath the human brain in the inner part of the skull. Only one bone adheres to it, and it is small like a barley grain, yet it is round, nearly square, and contains blood vessels resembling intertwined spider webs. Within these vessels, the five senses are established. This is the view of the sage Cordovero regarding the nature of the aforementioned bone, and so too brought by the author of Tzeror HaMor in the name of the Rambam (of blessed memory), although from the words of many it appears that it is the luz bone[1] at the end of a person's spine, where one bends during the Modim prayer, among the eighteen vertebrae of the spine. This bone lives forever, as mentioned in the Midrash and in Kohelet Rabbati, that "the anvil split but the

[A] Or: "luminous speculum" — The term 'speculum' more directly translates the Latin origin of the Hebrew/Aramaic term אספקלריאה, and is often used in kabbalistic translations. This might be preferred in more technical scholarly contexts, though it's less accessible to general readers.

[1] The luz bone (עצם לוז) is described in rabbinic literature as an indestructible bone from which the body will be regenerated during resurrection. Different traditions place it either at the base of the skull or at the base of the spine.

[i] This reveals a cyclical understanding of soul unity, where the normally separated soul components partially reunite during sacred times (Sabbath, festivals, and New Moons), reflecting the kabbalistic principle that sacred time creates opportunities for spiritual reunification.

[ii] The author connects the practical custom of not tying knots in burial shrouds with the mystical concept that the soul components (nefesh-ruach-neshamah) are not permanently bound together after death until the resurrection.

[iii] This vivid anatomical description of blood vessels resembling spider webs in the luz bone shows how the author integrates quasi-scientific observations with mystical concepts regarding the physical seat of resurrection.

באדריאנוס ששאל לר׳ יהושע מהיכן הקב״ה מציץ האדם לעתיד לבא. נראה שהוא עצם הנקרא לוז. ומצאתי כי נקרא בשם זה שהוא להיותו עצומו ועקרו שרשו וממנו נתהוה האדם בעצם הטפה והוא המקבל עונג ועונש אחר מיתת האדם ושרשו הוא מעצם השמים והמקובלים קראוהו שקד ובעל הסוד כתב בספרו כי לוז של יעקב נשתנה שמו בית אל[i] ובפרקי ר׳ אליעזר כתוב רב אמר אנא הוית בברכי חים ושמענא דהוו קריין לגרמא דשדרה דאשתאר מכל גופא בתואל רמאה ומצאתי בשם חכם כי האדם מיסוד השמים מחצה שהוא מהכבד ולמעלה ומשם ולמטה מיסוד הארץ[ii] ולכן אמרו על רבינו הקדוש שלא הושיט ידו למטה מטיבורו. ומיסוד השמים נשאר עצם אחד שאינו כלה. ואמרי׳ בויקרא רבה מהיכן נברא אדם מלוז של שדרה ולעתיד טל התחיה ירד על העצם הנשאר כפי דעת כל אחד ויעשה כשאור בעיסה ויתפשט לכאן ולכאן ויתמתחו מתוכו כל האברים וכל הגידים ועור ובשר ויתגלגלו עד ארץ ישראל ושם יקבלו רוחם.[iii] ואינו נהנה רק מסעודת שבת ויש אומרים מיין הבדלה לבד ודעת אחרים שאינו נהנה כלל מאכילה ושתיה

fire could not burn it,"[1] and therefore it is alive near the living. And in Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 18, there is a story about Hadrian who asked Rabbi Yehoshua: "From where will the Holy One, blessed be He, cause man to sprout in the future?" It appears that it is the bone called luz. 70R

I found that it is called by this name because it is his essence, his root and source, and from it a person is formed in the essence of the seed. It receives pleasure and punishment after a person's death, and its root is from the essence of the heavens. The Kabbalists called it "almond" (shaked), and the author of the Secret wrote in his book that Jacob's luz had its name changed to Bethel. In Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer it is written that Rav said: "I was in the coastal cities and heard that they called the bone of the spine that remains from the entire body 'the deceiver Bethuel.'" I found in the name of a sage that half of man is from the element of the heavens, from the liver upward, and from there downward is from the element of the earth. Therefore, they said of our holy Rabbi that he never extended his hand below his navel. From the element of the heavens, one bone remains that does not decay. 75R 80R 85R

It is said in Vayikra Rabbah: "From where was man created? From the luz of the spine." In the future, the dew of resurrection[A] will descend upon the remaining bone according to each one's worthiness, and it will act like leaven in dough, expanding in all directions. From within it will stretch forth all the limbs, sinews, skin, and flesh, and they will roll to the Land of Israel where they will receive their spirit. It benefits only from the Sabbath meal, and some say only from the wine of Havdalah, while others hold 90R 95R

[A] Or: "revivifying dew" — This alternative captures the active quality of the dew as something that causes revival or resurrection, rather than simply being associated with resurrection. It might be preferred for emphasizing the causal relationship.

[1] This refers to a Talmudic story (Sanhedrin 82b) where Emperor Hadrian attempted to destroy the luz bone by various means, including placing it on an anvil and striking it, but the anvil split while the bone remained intact.

[i] This references Genesis 28:19, where Jacob renamed the location Luz to Bethel after his dream of a ladder to heaven, creating a wordplay connecting the luz bone to this biblical site of divine revelation and transformation.

[ii] This division of the human body (above the liver from heaven, below from earth) reflects a cosmic anthropology where the human body mirrors larger cosmic structures, a concept found in many mystical traditions.

[iii] This refers to the rabbinic concept that during resurrection, the bodies of Jews buried outside the Land of Israel will roll through underground tunnels to reach the Holy Land, where resurrection will be completed.

ומדברי מדרש הנעלם בדף קל״ז נראה שהוא בשדרה ונקרא רמאה דלא סביל טעמא דמזונא כשאר גרמי ובן גם כן הוא התקיף משאר גרמי ובדף קט״ז ממנו מתבאר צורך התחיה ותקון הנשמה והגוף וגדולת בני התחיה כאשר נבאר לקמן בעה״י. ובין למר ובין למר חלק הנפש הנשאר בעצם הזה היינו נפש הבהמית הדבוקה בעפר ורקב העצמות וזהו שנאמר ועצמותיך יחליץ על סוד חדוש הנפש הזאת ממה שנפש הקדושה מתענגת ברוח ובנשמה בשבת ויו״ט. ואמרי׳ במדרש הנעלם דשלש כתות של מלאכי השרת הולכים בכל חדש ושבת ללוות הצדיקים בעלי נשמה קדושה ובהיות אדם רשע כתיב ונפשו עליו תאבל עד ירחמנו עושהו ויוצרו יחוננו בדין ובמשפט שלם: [i]

that it does not benefit at all from eating or drinking. From the words of the Hidden Midrash on page 137, it appears that it is in the spine and is called "deceiver" because it does not tolerate the taste of food like other bones, and it is also stronger than other bones. On page 116 of the same text, the need for resurrection, rectification of the soul and body, and the greatness of those who will be resurrected are explained, as we will clarify later, God willing.

Whether according to one opinion or the other, the portion of the nefesh that remains in this bone is the animal soul that clings to the dust and decay of the bones. This is what is meant by "He will invigorate your bones"—referring to the mystery of the renewal of this soul from what the holy soul enjoys with the ruach and neshamah on Sabbaths and festivals. It is said in the Hidden Midrash that three groups of ministering angels go each month and Sabbath to accompany the righteous who possess a holy soul. But when a person is wicked, it is written: "His soul will mourn over him[1] until his Maker has mercy on him and his Creator favors him with complete justice and judgment."

פרק ז׳

Chapter 7

אמרו רבנן במס׳ ברכות קשה רמה למת כמחט בבשר החי[ii] רצונם בזה אל סוד החושים

Our Sages said in Tractate Berakhot: "The worm is as painful to the dead as a needle to the flesh of the living."[2] Their intention here relates to the secret of

[1] This is a reference to Job 14:22, which is interpreted here as describing the state of a wicked person's soul after death, in contrast to the righteous whose souls are accompanied by angels.

[2] This is a direct translation of a Talmudic statement from Berakhot 18b that addresses the question of whether the dead have sensation. The author uses this to develop a kabbalistic understanding of how different soul components remain connected to the body after death.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — This reference establishes the hierarchical relationship between soul components after death, showing how the lower aspects connect to the higher ones in an upward spiritual progression rather than a downward connection to the physical body. | Cf. Hidden Midrash (Midrash HaNe'elam) in Parashat Toldot Yitzchak — The text uses this reference to support its cosmological model of where different soul components reside after death, specifically placing the neshamah in the highest realm. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah, Chapter 18 — The author uses this reference to support the concept of the luz bone as the physical basis for resurrection, showing how this belief has ancient rabbinic origins. | Cf. Kohelet Rabbati — The reference reinforces the concept of the luz bone's indestructibility, which is essential to its function as the physical seed for resurrection. | Cf. Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer — This reference provides an alternative name for the luz bone ('the deceiver Bethuel'), showing the author's scholarly breadth in collecting various traditions about this concept. | Cf. Tzeror HaMor — The author uses this reference to show that Maimonides (Rambam) supported the concept of an essential bone, though there are differing views about which specific bone this is.

[ii] This refers to a Talmudic statement in Berakhot 18b which discusses the sensation of the dead, suggesting that the deceased retain some form of awareness.

השוכנים בגוף הנזכר[i] וכבר
אמרנו כי הנפש הזאת אינה
פועלת בגוף כי הוא חלק השפל
בנפשו בלתי נרגש ועליה אמר
רב להההוא ספדנא אחים לו
בהספדאי דהתם קאימנא[ii] עם
חיות שאפשר לנו לומר שגם
רשימו מנפש רוח נשמה שם
בזמן הקבורה ואולי יחד כלם
במציאותם שם עומדים עד יהא
טמון בארץ חבלם[iii] וכן כל
השבעה ימים הראשונים יש להם
עדיין התקרבות גדול עם נרתקם
דשבקו בהאי עלמא כדאמרי׳
בפ׳ ויחי. ועיין בריקאנ״טי פ׳
וישב[iv] פי׳ מאמר קשה רמה למת
וכו׳ וראיה למה שאמרנו ממרים
שלא נסתלק הבאר שהיה בזכותה
עד אחר קבורתה[v] דכתיב
ותמת ותקבר ואח״כ ולא היה
מים לעדה. וזכות הצדיקים
מועיל הרבה לעולם הזה
בשבעת ימים הראשונים אחר
פטירתם דז׳ ימים של אבלו
של מתושלח שמשה האורה
לעולם.[vi] ולהיות כי יש לגוף
חיות מה בקבר על כן מועיל
לפיס הנפטר על קברו כדאמרי׳
בגמרין ובירושלמי דיומא צריך
מפייסתיה על קבריה ומימר
סרחין עלך[vii] מלבד כי מדור

the senses dwelling in the aforementioned body. We have already stated that this soul does not function in the body, for it is the lowly part of one's soul, imperceptible, and concerning this Rav said to a certain eulogizer, "Speak passionately in my eulogy, for I will be standing there," although we could say that there remains an impression of the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah[1] at the time of burial, and perhaps all of them together in their entirety stand there until the body is hidden in the earth. Similarly, during all the first seven days, they still maintain a strong connection with their vessel that they left in this world, as stated in the portion of Vayechi.[2] See also Recanati on the portion of Vayeshev, where he explains the statement "The worm is as painful to the dead," etc.

Evidence for what we have said comes from Miriam, as the well that existed in her merit did not depart until after her burial, as it is written, "And she died and was buried," and only afterward, "And there was no water for the congregation." The merit of the righteous greatly benefits this world during the seven days following their passing, as demonstrated by the seven days of mourning for Methuselah when light continued to shine for the world. Since the body retains some vitality in the grave, it is beneficial to appease the deceased at their grave, as stated in our Gemara and in the Jerusalem Talmud of Yoma: "One must appease them at their grave and say, 'I have sinned against you.'" Moreover, the dwelling place of the soul in the Court of Death[3] is specifically in the air opposite

[1] These are the three primary levels of the soul in Kabbalah: nefesh (vital soul, lowest level), ruach (spirit, middle level), and neshamah (divine soul, highest level). The text discusses how these components gradually disconnect from the body after death.

[2] The author is referring to Zoharic commentary on the Torah portion Vayechi (Genesis 47:28-50:26), which discusses the state of the soul after death and its continued connection to the body during the first seven days.

[3] This translates 'chatzar mavet,' a kabbalistic term for the spiritual realm immediately surrounding

[i] The text references a kabbalistic concept that certain sensory capacities remain in the body after death, connected to the lowest level of the soul.

[ii] This is a quotation from the Talmud (Shabbat 153a) where Rav instructs a eulogizer to speak passionately at his funeral because he (Rav) would be present.

[iii] This phrase suggests that the soul components remain connected to the body until burial is complete, reflecting the Jewish emphasis on prompt burial.

[iv] Rabbi Menahem Recanati was a 14th-century Italian kabbalist. The reference is to his commentary on the Torah portion Vayeshev.

[v] According to rabbinic tradition, a miraculous well followed the Israelites in the desert due to Miriam's merit, and it disappeared only after her burial, not immediately upon her death.

[vi] This refers to a midrashic tradition that during the seven days of mourning for Methuselah, who died just before the Flood, God delayed the Flood and the light continued to shine.

[vii] This refers to the practice of asking forgiveness from the deceased at their grave, literally saying

הנפש בחצר מות[i] הוא באויר שנגד הקבר דווקא ואיך יודיעו למתים צער החיים ומה תועיל התפלה בבית הקברות אם לא ישהה בקבר חלק חיות מה.

ואמרי׳ בזהר צדיקיא אע״ג דאתפטרו בהאי עלמא לא אסתלקו[ii] כי נשאר הרגש בגופם בקבר עם היות נשמתם בישיבה העליונה ומשה האיר ליהושע אף אחר מותו כשמש שמאיר לירח בלילה[iii] ואמרו בפ׳ שמות דאי לאו בעותא דמיתי על חיי[iv] לא יתקיימון פלגות יומא: ולהיות לנפש הבהמית הזאת ב׳ חלקים[v] חלק א׳ ימשך אחר הגוף בתאוות גשמיות והיא מרכבה ליצר הרע כדפירשו בזהר פ׳ וירא וחלק שני הוא מרכבה אל הנפש כדפי׳ והחלק שהיא מרכבה אל יצה״ר הוא סוד עכנא[vi] דמערתא הנזכר כמה פעמים בעניין הנחש שהוא מרכבה אל

the grave, so how could the living inform the dead of their suffering, and what benefit would prayer at the cemetery provide if no aspect of vitality remained in the grave?

It is stated in the Zohar that even though the righteous depart from this world, they do not completely leave, for sensation remains in their bodies in the grave, even though their souls are in the heavenly academy. Moses illuminated Joshua even after his death, just as the sun illuminates the moon at night. And it is stated in the portion of Shemot that if not for the prayers of the dead on behalf of the living,[1] they would not survive half a day.

This animal soul[2] has two parts: one part is drawn after the body in physical desires and serves as a vehicle for the evil inclination,[3] as explained in the Zohar in the portion of Vayera; the second part serves as a vehicle for the [higher] soul, as explained. The part that serves as a vehicle for the evil inclination is the secret of the "snake of the cav[4]e" mentioned several times, similar to the serpent that is a vehicle for Samael, the primordial serpent.[5]

a grave, where the nefesh (lowest soul component) is believed to dwell after death.

[1]This reflects the Jewish mystical belief that the righteous deceased continue to intercede for the living, which forms the basis for the tradition of visiting graves to request such intercession.

[2]This translates 'nefesh ha-behamit,' the lowest level of the soul associated with basic physical functions and desires. In kabbalistic psychology, it's divided between aspects that are drawn to physical desires and aspects that can be elevated to serve higher spiritual purposes.

[3]This translates 'merkavah l'yetzer ha-ra,' using the concept of 'merkavah' (chariot/vehicle) to describe how one part of the animal soul can become a vessel or instrument for the evil inclination.

[4]This translates 'ikhna d'me'arta,' a kabbalistic symbol for negative spiritual forces associated with death and the grave, compared here to the primordial serpent (representing Samael/Satan).

[5]Samael is the name of an important angel of death or accuser in Jewish mystical tradition, often identified with Satan and with the serpent from the Garden of Eden story.

"I have sinned against you." This practice is based on the belief that the deceased can hear and respond.

[i]"Court of Death" (Chatzar Mavet) is a kabbalistic term for the space around a grave where the lowest level of the soul (nefesh) is believed to dwell after death.

[ii]This Zoharic statement means "the righteous, even though they have departed from this world, have not [completely] left," suggesting the continued presence and influence of the righteous after death.

[iii]This is a metaphorical description of posthumous spiritual influence, comparing Moses' continued guidance of Joshua after death to how the sun's light is reflected by the moon at night.

[iv]"The prayers of the dead on behalf of the living"—this reflects the Jewish belief that the deceased can intercede on behalf of the living, which is the basis for the custom of visiting graves to ask the righteous deceased to pray for the living.

[v]The text divides the "animal soul" (nefesh ha-behamit) into two parts: one drawn to physical desires (connected to the evil inclination) and one that serves as a vehicle for the higher soul.

[vi]"Snake of the cave" is a kabbalistic symbol for a negative spiritual force associated with the grave, drawing a parallel to the primordial serpent (representing Samael/Satan) in the Garden of Eden story.

ס״מ נחש הקדמוני. ואיתא בזהר
בשעה שמת עובדיה בא הנושה
יהורם לקחת בניו[i] הלבה אשתו
גועה ובוכה בבית הקברות
וצעקה ירא אלהים כך וכך
עושים ליתומיך אמר לה וכו׳ עד
דאמרו ליה אמור לה שתלך אצל
אלישע וכן עשתה. ומזה יובן
קבורת הצדיקים במקום ידוע
בגון אצל משפחתו או צדיק אצל
צדיק וכיוצא כי יש קרוב דעת
אל הנפשות בעולם ההוא מפני
יחס הבן עם אביו בנפש רוח
נשמה וכ״ש בנפש הבהמית כי
היא נפש ירושה אל הבן מן האב
וכן הצדיקים להיותם מעלתם
שוה ונהנים זה מזה[ii] כדמיון
הנאת השכנים בעולם הגשמי
כך הנאתם אחר המות ומעשה
דהנהו רוחי דמסכתא ברכות
יוכיח[iii] ועוד נדבר בזה לקמן.
וכתוב בספר הזהר דנוקבא
דאתנסיבת לתרין דבההוא
עלמא אהדרת לקדמאה.[iv] על
דרך אין האשה כורתת ברית
אלא למי שעשאה כלי:[v] [vi]

It is stated in the Zohar that when Obadiah died, the creditor Jehoram came to take his sons [as slaves]. His wife went weeping and crying at the cemetery, and cried out, "O God-fearing man, is this what they do to your orphans?" He said to her... until they told him, "Tell her to go to Elisha," and so she did. From this we can understand the burial of the righteous in a specific place, such as near their family or a righteous person next to another righteous person, because there is a closeness of mind among souls in that world due to the relationship between son and father in nefesh, ruach, and neshamah, especially in the animal soul, for it is a soul inherited by the son from the father. Similarly, the righteous, being of equal status, derive pleasure from one another, just as neighbors benefit from each other in the physical world; such is their pleasure after death. The incident of those spirits in Tractate Berakhot proves this, and we will discuss this further below. It is written in the Zohar that a woman who married twice returns to her first husband in the World to Come, following the principle that "a woman forms a covenant only with the one who made her a vessel."[1]

60R 65R 70R 75R 80R

[1] This is a somewhat euphemistic translation of a Talmudic saying about the special bond formed through first marital relations, applied here in a mystical context to explain soul connections that persist beyond death.

[i] This refers to a story in the Zohar based on 2 Kings 4:1, where the prophet Elisha helps the widow of a prophet (identified here as Obadiah) whose creditor came to take her sons as slaves.

[ii] This explains the kabbalistic rationale for burying righteous people near each other—their souls benefit from proximity in the afterlife just as people benefit from good neighbors in this world.

[iii] This likely refers to the story in Berakhot 18b about spirits conversing in the cemetery, which is cited as evidence for the continued awareness and communication of souls after death.

[iv] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar states that a woman who married twice returns to her first husband in the World to Come, reflecting kabbalistic beliefs about soul connections that transcend death.

[v] This Talmudic saying (Sanhedrin 22b) means that a woman forms a permanent spiritual bond only with her first husband. In kabbalistic thought, this reflects the idea of essential soul connections that persist beyond death.

[vi] Cf. Zohar, Vayechi — The author cites this source to establish the kabbalistic understanding that soul components remain connected to the body for seven days after death, forming a basis for the mourning practices. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 18b — The author uses this Talmudic statement as a starting point to develop a kabbalistic understanding of post-mortem consciousness and sensation. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat 153a — The author cites this as evidence that the deceased are present at their own funerals, supporting the kabbalistic belief in continued awareness after death. | Cf. Midrash on Miriam's well — The author uses this as evidence that the merit of the righteous continues to benefit the world between their death and burial, supporting his larger argument about the gradual separation of soul components. | Cf. Zohar, Shemot — The author cites this to establish the kabbalistic belief that the deceased, particularly the righteous, continue

פרק ח׳

מכל מה שאמרנו יובן טעם
לבוש המתים שכמו שנכנסים
בקבר כן ממש מתלבש הכת
ההוא שבקבר ברוחניות הלבוש
הגשמי שמוליך עמו כי אין דבר
גשמי שאין בו כח מלמעלה. וכן
אותו כח שבמלבושים ההם ממש
מלביש הנפש הגשמית אף אם
ירקבו התכריכים וזהו טעם
רבן גמליאל שאמר שלא אהיה
כחתן בין האבלים ולא כאבל
בין החתנים.[i] וכן ענין המחצלת
הנזכר במסכת ברכות: ובפרשת
בראשית דף ל״ח ע״ב כתב רשב״י
מגו ההוא מנא דאתלבשת ביה בגן
עדן תחתון חמאת דיוקנין עילאין
לאסתכלא ביקרא דמאריהון
ובפ׳ חקת אמר משה הוה פשיט
בגדי אהרן למטה והקב״ה פשיט
למעלה יע״ש. וכן הכתוב אומר
ויתיצבו כמו לבוש ואמרו רבנן

Chapter 8

From all that we have said, the reason for the clothing of the dead can be understood: just as they enter the grave, so too does that group in the grave truly clothe itself in the spirituality of the physical garment[A1] that accompanies it, for there is no physical thing that does not have a force from above.[2] And thus, that same force in those garments truly clothes the physical soul, even if the shrouds decay. This is the reason Rabban Gamliel said, "Let me not appear as a bridegroom among mourners, nor as a mourner among bridegrooms." And this is also the matter of the mat mentioned in Tractate Berakhot.[B]

In the portion of Genesis, page 38b, Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai wrote: "Through that vessel in which it is clothed in the lower Garden of Eden, it sees supernal forms to gaze upon the glory of their Master." And in the portion of Chukat, it says: "Moses was removing Aaron's garments below, and the Holy One, blessed be He, was removing them above,"[C] see there. Similarly, Scripture says, "They

[A] Or: "that spiritual entity in the grave truly clothe itself in the spirituality of the physical garment" — The term 'הכת ההוא' in this mystical context likely refers more specifically to a spiritual entity or aspect of the soul rather than a 'group,' which could be clearer for readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology about soul components.

[B] Or: "And such is the matter of the reed mat mentioned in Tractate Berakhot" — The Hebrew term 'מחצלת' specifically refers to a reed or straw mat, which might be significant in the Talmudic context being referenced. Adding this specificity could be helpful for readers trying to locate the reference.

[C] Or: "Moses was stripping Aaron's garments below while the Holy One, blessed be He, was

[1] The original Hebrew phrase 'הכת ההוא שבקבר' (that group in the grave) seems to refer to the soul components that remain connected to the grave after death, particularly the nefesh according to kabbalistic thought.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic principle that all physical objects have spiritual counterparts or 'roots' in higher worlds. The physical garments have spiritual counterparts that remain even after the physical garments decay.

to intercede for the living after death. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Yoma — The author uses this to support the belief that the deceased remain aware of the actions of the living and can be appeased, forming a basis for cemetery prayer practices. | Cf. Zohar, Vayera — The author references this to explain the kabbalistic understanding of how the lower soul component can serve as a vehicle for either negative or positive spiritual forces. | Cf. Recanati, Commentary on Vayeshev — The author cites this commentary to add depth to his kabbalistic explanation of post-mortem sensation and awareness. | Cf. Zohar, story of Obadiah's widow — The author uses this story to demonstrate that the deceased can hear those who call to them at their graves and can even respond or provide guidance. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Sanhedrin 22b — The author uses this to explain the Zoharic teaching that a woman who married twice returns to her first husband in the afterlife, reflecting the kabbalistic concept of essential soul connections that transcend death.

[i] This is a reference to Rabban Gamliel's instructions regarding his burial shrouds, found in Tractate Ketubot 8b. He was concerned with appropriate appearance in different contexts even after death.

כסות היורדת עם האדם לשאול היא עולה עמו ק״ו מחטה וכו׳. ואפי׳ נשרף האדם הרוח מתלבש בריח מלבושיו וכן כשהתכריכין בלין הרוח מתלבש בסוד התכריכין ההם אך אם נפשטו מעליו אין לרוח במה להתלבש ובמדרש רבה פ׳ וילך אמר כי יש תכריכין ממעשה שמים וכן ארון ומטה ממעשה שמים. ולב המתעסקים יהיה לעורר המקורות העליונים ההם. לכן חנניה מישאל ועזריה הושלכו לכבשן האש בסרבלהון וגו׳. וכן פרה אדומה עורה ובשרה ופרשה ועצמותיה הכל נשרף לטהר טמאי מתים המקבלים טומאת המת גם מבחינת לבושיהם ואמרו כי יכולים המתים להתלבש בלבושים אחרים כמו שהמלאכים המושלים לעיני חוש מתלבשים צורה אנושית ואמרו כי לוקחים חלק מן שלג אשר תחת כסא הכבוד שממנו נתהוה הארץ כדוגמא זו תהיה התלבשות לבעלי העבודה. ויש מלבוש אחר כעובדא דאחאי בר יאשיה שהושם בו אז כח הדבריי. ורבינו הקדוש היה נר׳ בבגדי חמודות שהיה לובש בשבת ולא בתכריכין[i] וודאי אם באותה שעה היו מחפשים בקברו היו מוצאים עצמותיו או גופו אלא היה התלבשות

stand as a garment,"[1] and the Rabbis said, "The garment that descends with a person to the grave ascends with him," which is derived a fortiori from wheat, etc.[2]

Even if a person is burned, the spirit clothes itself in the scent of his garments, and likewise when the shrouds deteriorate, the spirit clothes itself in the essence of those shrouds. But if they are stripped from him, the spirit has nothing in which to clothe itself. In Midrash Rabbah, portion of Vayelech, it states that there are shrouds made by heaven, and likewise a coffin and a bed made by heaven. The hearts of those who engage [in burial] should be to awaken those supernal sources. That is why Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah were cast into the fiery furnace in their garments, etc. Similarly, the red heifer—its hide, flesh, waste, and bones—all are burned to purify those defiled by the dead, who receive impurity from the dead also from the aspect of their garments.

They said that the dead can clothe themselves in other garments, just as angels who rule over the sense of sight clothe themselves in human form. They said that they take a portion from the snow beneath the Throne of Glory, from which the earth was formed. In this manner would be the clothing for those engaged in divine service. And there is another garment, as in the case of Achai bar Yoshiyah, in which the power of speech was then placed.[A] And our holy Rabbi [Judah the Prince] appeared in the precious garments he would wear on Sabbath, not in shrouds. Certainly, if at that time they had searched his grave, they would have found his bones or his body, but it was a clothing in the likeness of his body,

stripping them above" — The verb 'פשיט' has a more forceful connotation of 'stripping' or 'peeling off' rather than simply 'removing,' which might better capture the mystical parallelism between the earthly and heavenly actions being described in this passage.

[A] Or: "And there exists another type of garment, as in the case of Achai bar Yoshiyah, who was granted the power of speech [after death]" — This alternate translation clarifies that the reference is to a post-mortem ability to speak, which is the key point of the Talmudic story being referenced, making the miraculous nature of the account more explicit.

[1] This is likely a reference to Job 38:14, which in context discusses how the earth takes form like clay under a seal and 'stands forth as a garment.' The author applies this metaphorically to spiritual garments.

[2] This refers to a Talmudic argument: if a grain of wheat buried naked sprouts clothed in many husks, surely a human buried in shrouds will be resurrected with garments (Sanhedrin 90b).

[i] This refers to a famous Talmudic account (Ketubot 103a) where Rabbi Judah the Prince (Rabbeinu HaKadosh) would appear to his household after death every Friday evening wearing Sabbath clothes to recite the Kiddush.

בדמות גופו הניכר לבני ביתו
וזה לא ימצא אלא בחסידים
שהם כבני בית למעלה וניתן
להם בקשתם וכן שמואל ודאי כי
לא זז מקברו וגם כי יש סברות
אחרות זה הנכון לדעתנו. ואולי
יורה שלהיות אז שבת היה עליו
הארת שגרם בסוד התלבשות
עולם האצילות בבריאה שהם
בגדי חמודות.[i] ולכן שנוי בגדים
הוא מן התורה ובפרט בשבת כי
צריך להפשיט מעליו הנהגות
ובגדי החול וללבוש בבגדי
מלכות ואמרי׳ בירושלמי אוי
לנו עטיפתנו בשבת היא כעטיפת
החול. ורבי שהיה ודאי מכבד
השבת בבגדים יקרים מפרי ידיו
הלבישוהו אחרי מותו ועוד
היה מתראה בבגדי חמודות
להודיע שהיה בתוקפו. והיה
פוטר בני הבית מן הקידוש ולא
כשאר מתים שהם חפשים מן
המצות.[ii] המבין סוד הקידוש
עם מה שכתבנו למעלה בסוד
מקדש השבת יבוין דברינו בטעם
אמירתו קידוש יותר מכל שאר
קדושות ואז היו עליו לבושי
דיקר מעין אותם של אדם
הראשון ובזהר שמות דף ר״ח
ביאר ממה היו לבושים אלו:
ואמרו בפרשת בא דף ל״ט כי
לבושי אדם וחוה נעשו בשם
מלא ונתקיימו ג״כ בשם מלא
ותרגום כתנות עור הוא לבושין
דיקר ואמר שלא באו ליד נמרוד
כדעת המדרש[iii] אלא כי אדם
וחוה אתקברו בהון דלא ס״ד

recognizable to his household. This is found only among the pious, who are like family members above, and their requests are granted. Likewise, Samuel certainly did not move from his grave, and although there are other opinions, this is correct in our view. 60R

Perhaps this indicates that because it was then Sabbath, he had upon him the illumination that was caused by the secret of the World of Emanation being clothed in the World of Creation, which are precious garments. Therefore, changing clothes is [a requirement] from the Torah, especially on Sabbath, for one must remove from oneself the conduct and weekday garments and clothe oneself in royal garments. They said in the Jerusalem Talmud, "Woe to us! Our wrapping on Sabbath is like our wrapping on weekdays." And Rabbi [Judah], who certainly honored the Sabbath with precious garments from the fruit of his hands, they clothed him after his death, and furthermore he would appear in precious garments to show that he was in his full power.[1] And he would exempt the members of the household from [reciting] Kiddush, unlike other dead who are free from commandments. 65R 70R 75R

One who understands the secret of Kiddush, along with what we wrote above regarding the secret of sanctifying the Sabbath,[2] will comprehend our words concerning the reason for reciting Kiddush more than all other sanctifications. And then he had upon him precious garments like those of Adam, the first man. In the Zohar, Exodus page 208, it explains what these garments were. 80R 85R

They said in the portion of Bo, page 39, that the garments of Adam and Eve were made with the full Name and were sustained also with the full Name. The translation of "garments of skin" is "precious garments." And it says that they did not come into Nimrod's possession, as the Midrash 90R

[1] The text suggests that Rabbi Judah's appearance in Sabbath garments after death was not merely customary but demonstrated his continued spiritual authority and potency in the afterlife.

[2] The author implies that Kiddush has deeper kabbalistic significance beyond its literal meaning as sanctification of the Sabbath day, connecting it to cosmic processes of divine unification.

[i] The author is offering a kabbalistic interpretation of why Rabbi Judah appeared in Sabbath garments, suggesting that on Sabbath there is a unique relationship between the higher world of Atzilut (Emanation) and Beriah (Creation) that manifests as precious garments.

[ii] This references the Talmudic principle that 'the dead are free from commandments' (במתים חפשי), while highlighting that Rabbi Judah the Prince was exceptional in continuing to fulfill the commandment of Kiddush even after death.

[iii] The author is contrasting the Zohar's view with a midrashic tradition that claimed Nimrod obtained Adam's original garments, which gave him power as a mighty hunter.

דאינון שבקו ורמו מנהון זיהרא
עילאה דיהיב לון קב״ה ולא
אתלבש בהו בר נש אחרא דאינון
לבושין דמו בגוונא עילאה וס״ד
דאינון אתלבשו בהון מגרמיהון
כתיב וילבישם. דקב״ה אלביש
לון זכאה חולקהון[i] ובקב״ה
כתיב הוד והדר לבשת והדר
עוטה אור כשלמה כיון דאתלבש
עבד מה דעבד ונוכל לומר
שבא להודיענו שלא נתגלה
אור האצילות לברוא וליהנות
לנבראים תחתונים עד שנתלבש
בבריאה כדאמרי׳ מלמד
שנתעטף הקב״ה באור וברא
את השמים[ii] ומכאן נבין גם כן
צורך הלבושים לנפש רוח נשמה.
ואמרי׳ בפרשת ויקהל דף קנ״ז
כי משה אתלבש בעננא וביה
תקריב לגבי אשא וכן אליהו
אתלבש בההיא סערה לעילא
ובאופן אחד מתראה למעלה
בין המלאכים. הנה כי על
ידי הלבושים מתראים הנשמות
למעלה: [iii]

opines, but rather Adam and Eve were buried in them, for it would not enter one's mind that they abandoned and cast away from themselves the supernal radiance that the Holy One, blessed be He, gave them. No other person clothed himself in them, for those garments resembled the supernal pattern. And it would not enter one's mind that they clothed themselves in them on their own; it is written, "And He clothed them"—the Holy One, blessed be He, clothed them. Fortunate was their portion! Regarding the Holy One, blessed be He, it is written: "You are clothed in glory and majesty," and "He wraps Himself in light as with a garment." Once He clothed Himself, He did what He did.

We can say that this comes to inform us that the light of Emanation was not revealed to create and benefit lower creations until it was clothed in Creation, as they said: "This teaches that the Holy One, blessed be He, wrapped Himself in light and created the heavens." From here we also understand the need for garments for the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah [soul levels]. They said in the portion of Vayakhel, page 157, that Moses clothed himself in a cloud and through it approached the fire, and likewise Elijah clothed himself in that storm above, and in one manner appears above among the angels. In-

[i] The Aramaic phrase translates as 'the Holy One, blessed be He, clothed them—fortunate was their portion!' This emphasizes that Adam and Eve's garments were divinely created, not self-made.

[ii] This is a reference to a rabbinic teaching found in Bereishit Rabbah 3:4, describing God's creation process through the metaphor of wrapping in light.

[iii] Cf. Tractate Berakhot — The reference supports the author's argument about spiritual garments by citing a Talmudic precedent that discusses burial materials and their significance. | Cf. Zohar, Genesis 38b — This Zoharic passage is used to establish the mystical principle that souls require appropriate garments to function in different spiritual realms, supporting the author's argument about the importance of burial shrouds. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Chukat — This reference illustrates the principle that physical actions with garments have corresponding spiritual effects in higher realms, a central concept in the author's explanation of burial shrouds. | Cf. Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah in the fiery furnace — The author uses this biblical story to demonstrate the spiritual power of garments, suggesting that their clothes had mystical protective properties that relate to the spiritual significance of burial shrouds. | Cf. Red heifer ritual — The author draws a parallel between the comprehensive burning of the red heifer (including its hide) and the significance of garments in spiritual purification, supporting the idea that clothing carries spiritual properties. | Cf. Story of Achai bar Yoshiyah — This reference supports the author's claim that righteous souls can manifest with spiritual garments after death, demonstrating that the clothing of the deceased has ongoing spiritual significance. | Cf. Rabbi Judah the Prince appearing after death — This story is central to the author's argument that righteous souls continue to manifest in appropriate spiritual garments after death, with Sabbath garments representing higher spiritual states. | Cf. Garments of Adam and Eve — This Zoharic passage is used to establish the primordial connection between divine garments and human clothing, suggesting that burial shrouds have a connection to these original divine garments. | Cf. Moses clothed in cloud and Elijah in storm — This reference concludes the author's argument by showing that even the greatest prophets required appropriate spiritual 'clothing' to navigate different spiritual realms, reinforcing the importance of proper burial garments.

deed, through garments the souls appear above.[1]

פרק ט׳

בזהר סוף פרשת ויקהל אמרו דזמין קב״ה להלביש לכל אחד מבני התחיה לבושי רקמה שאז יהיה עיקר שכר הצדיקים ממעשיהם ויבואו כלם וישתחוו לו בירושלים ויתחברו שם חיילות גדולות וירושלים תתמשך לכל הצדדים ובני התחיה יכירו זה את זה ויחזרו לירושת אבותם ולאחוזתם וילמדו תורה בארץ ישראל שתתעלה מעלה מעלה: ואמרו עוד שלהיות שנשמת האדם המדברת אינה מתה לפיכך יחלום החי מן המת שכח זה החי מתעורר לחי אבל הבהמה שמתה אין לה נשמת החכמה לפיכך לא יחלום האדם מבהמה שמתה או נשחטה ואמרו כי לא נתן רשות לנפש להגיד לאוהבו שבעה״ז גזירות של מעלה מבלי אשר לא ימצא האדם את מעשה האלהים. אמרנו כי המתים מתהנים בהיותם קבורים אצל כיוצא בהם ובבראשית רבה פרשה ע׳ למה בכה יעקב שאינה נכנסת עמו לקבורה. וכמו כן כבוד הוא לאדם להקבר בקבר שלו לכן נהגו לקנות אחוזת קרקע כנראה במשנת בב״ב וכן בגמ׳ פרק יש נוחלין על ואלעזר בן אהרן מת ויקברו אותו בגבעת פנחס בנו וכתב נ״י בדף ר״ט לא היה כבוד לאותו צדיק שיהיה נקבר בקבר שאינו שלו. וזה כי כמו שמדורו בגן עדן הוא לפי מעשיו כי הנשמה יגיע בפיה תאכל. כי מאן דאכיל דלאו דיליה בהיל לאסתכולי ביה. כן

Chapter 9

At the end of Parashat Vayakhel in the Zohar, they said that the Holy One, blessed be He, will clothe each of the resurrected with embroidered garments, for then the main reward of the righteous will come from their deeds. They will all come and bow before Him in Jerusalem, where great hosts will gather. Jerusalem will extend in all directions, and those who are resurrected will recognize one another. They will return to their ancestral inheritance and possessions, and will study Torah in the Land of Israel, which will be elevated higher and higher.

They further said that since the speaking soul of a human does not die, a living person may dream of the deceased, as this living power awakens to the living. However, when an animal dies, it lacks the soul of wisdom, therefore a person will not dream of an animal that has died or been slaughtered. They also said that a soul is not permitted to reveal heavenly decrees to its beloved in this world, lest humans discover the workings of God.

We have stated that the deceased derive benefit from being buried near others like them. In Genesis Rabbah, chapter 70, it explains why Jacob wept—because she [Rachel] would not enter the grave with him. Similarly, it is an honor for a person to be buried in his own grave. This is why the custom developed to purchase burial plots, as seen in the Mishnah of Bava Batra and in the Gemara chapter "Yesh Nochlin" regarding "Eleazar son of Aaron died, and they buried him in Gibeah of Phinehas his son." Nimukei Yosef wrote on page 209 that it would not have been honorable for that righteous man to be buried in a grave that was not his own. This is because just as one's dwelling in the Garden of Eden is according to one's deeds,[2] for "the soul eats of the labor of its hands," and "one who eats what is not his own is anxious when looking at it," so too must the body have a place purchased with money. Thus Abraham said, "Let him give it to me for the

[1] The conclusion emphasizes that spiritual garments are not merely coverings but essential vehicles that enable souls to manifest and function in higher spiritual realms, just as physical garments enable social functioning in the physical world.

[2] This reflects the Jewish concept that souls occupy different levels in the afterlife based on their merits, with the Garden of Eden having multiple sections or levels of different spiritual quality.

צריך שיהיה לגוף מקום מקנת כספו. וכן אברהם אמר בכסף מלא יתננה לי. ועוד סוד תקון העפר בעי למזבן יתיה בכסף שלים ודי למבין. וג״כ נייחא לצדיקים להיות צמודים בגן עדן שכן הובא בזהר פ׳ ויחי דר״י אמר לרבי יצחק דיבריר דוכתיה גביה כמה דהוה בהאי עלמא. ואשה הקבורה אצל בעלה ודאי נייחא רבה הוא לתרווייהו. ונ״ל שנאמרה על אשתו ראשונה היינו אותה שעמדה אצלו בפרגוד ולכן אמרו המגרש אשתו ראשונה דוקא אפילו מזבח מוריד עליו דמעות כי גורם הפרדת שפע שבעה ברכות שנתברכו בשעת חופתם במזבח העליון המקבל ממה שלמעלה ממנו ובפרט אם היו לו בנים ממנה נוכל להאמין שהיא עיקר זוגתו הראשונה שבגן עדן שעליה יוצאה הבת קול בת פלוני לפלוני והוא נקרא זווג ראשון וכתוב בספר הבהיר כי ז׳ צורות קדושות ברא הקב״ה והם צורות נחלקות שתי ידים שתי רגלים הראש והגוף הרי שש וצורה הז׳ היא הנקבה הרי שהאשה משלמת כל הז׳ צורות והקב״ה חבר בבריאת אדם כל הז׳ צורות יחד ואחרי כן הפריד השביעית ואין האיש נשלם עולתה ע״כ תקנו שבעת ימי המשתה וכן ז׳ ברכות וברכה שביעית משלמת כל שאר הברכות וחותמים בה משמח חתן עם הכלה. וכשאין פנים חדשות יכול לברך השביעית בלתי האחרות אבל לא האחרות בלתי

full price." There is also a secret concerning the rectification of the dust—that one needs to purchase it with full payment,[A] and this is sufficient for those who understand. 40R

It is also restful for the righteous to be joined together in the Garden of Eden, as brought in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, where Rabbi Yochanan said to Rabbi Yitzchak that he should select a place for himself near him, just as he was in this world. And a woman buried next to her husband certainly brings great satisfaction to both of them. It seems to me that this was said specifically about one's first wife—the one who stood with him behind the heavenly curtain. That is why they said that one who divorces his first wife, specifically—even the altar sheds tears over him, for he causes the separation of the flow of the seven blessings with which they were blessed at the time of their wedding at the supernal altar, which receives from what is above it. Especially if he had children with her, we may believe that she is his essential first mate from the Garden of Eden, about whom the heavenly voice proclaims, "The daughter of so-and-so is destined for so-and-so," and this is called the first union. 45R 50R 55R 60R

It is written in Sefer HaBahir that the Holy One, blessed be He, created seven holy forms, which are divided forms: two hands, two legs, the head, and the body—these are six—and the seventh form is the female. Thus, the woman completes all seven forms. The Holy One, blessed be He, joined all seven forms together in the creation of Adam, and afterward separated the seventh. A man is not complete without her. Therefore, they instituted the seven days of the wedding feast,[1] as well as the seven blessings, with the seventh blessing completing all the other blessings. They conclude it with "Who gladdens the groom with the bride." When there are no new faces present, one can recite the seventh blessing without the others,[2] but not the others without the seventh. 65R 70R 75R

[A] Or: "a mystical principle of earth's rectification requiring its purchase with complete payment" — This alternate translation emphasizes more clearly the kabbalistic concept of 'tikkun' (rectification) that is central to the phrase, while rendering 'sod' as 'mystical principle' rather than 'secret' better conveys the nature of the teaching.

[1] The text draws a parallel between the seven wedding blessings (sheva berakhot), the seven-day wedding celebration, and the seven divine forms completed by the union of male and female, creating a cosmic significance for marriage rituals.

[2] The text refers to the halakhic principle that when there are no new guests (panim chadashot) at a sheva berakhot meal during the week following a wedding, only the final blessing ('Who gladdens

השביעית רמז לפנים חדשות של
האשה שמשלמת לאדם כל שבעה
צורות וכמו שהשבת מנוחה
לששה ימים כן האשה מנוחה
לשש צורות כי האדם זולתה
מטולטל ונד ולכן אין נפטר
האדם מפריה ורביה עד שיוליד
זכר ונקבה והם יולידו השבע
צורות ואשתו הראשונה היא
עיקר צורתו והשאר כמו הפקר
שהראשונה חתומה עמו בחשמל
כמו שרמזנו למעלה מזה וכמו
שמשלמת האדם בחייו כן משלמת
אותו במותו במקום משכן כבודו:
ובסבא דף ק״ב נתן טעם למה אין
האשה מתיישבת כראוי עם בעלה
השני ושם פירשו סוד הקטלנית
וסכנה גדולה ממי שנושא אלמנה
ומלת אלמנה אמרו שירצה אל
מנה אל תפול זאת למנה וחלק
שום אדם כשר ובפרט אם בעלה
הראשון הוא ת״ח שבמיתתו הוא
חי ושפתי תורתו דובבות בקברו
והיו לה בנים ממנו בלי ספק כי
לא תהיה לה קורת רוח עם אחר.
ובפרט אם יהיה אחרון לגבי
ראשון ושניהם מסתכנים ונראה
זה פעמים הרבה לחוש ואין
להטפל להשיא אשת ת״ח ובפרט
לע״ה כי לא יצליחו. בכלי
שנשתמש בו קדש אל ישתמש בו
חול ואין זה נאה ללבושו ולא
לבושו לו דכרעא דרב ממאניה
לא לבעי ליה: [i]

This alludes to the new presence of the woman, who completes all seven forms for man. Just as the Sabbath provides rest for the six days, so too does the woman provide rest for the six forms, because without her, man is unsettled and wandering. Therefore, a man is not released from the obligation of procreation until he begets a male and a female, who will produce the seven forms.

His first wife is his essential form, and the others are like ownerless property, for the first is sealed with him in the Chashmal (divine luminous substance),[A] as we alluded to above. Just as she completes the man in his lifetime, so does she complete him in his death, in the place of his glorious dwelling.

In Saba (the Elder's teaching), page 102, a reason is given why a woman does not settle properly with her second husband. There they explained the secret of the "killer wife" and the great danger for one who marries a widow. They said the word "almanah" (widow) implies "al manah"[B]—"let this not fall to the portion and share of any worthy person," especially if her first husband was a Torah scholar who in his death is still alive, with the lips of his Torah teachings murmuring in his grave. If she had children with him, there is no doubt that she will not find contentment with another, especially if the second husband is inferior compared to the first. Both are endangered, and this has been observed many times to be a concern. One should not take pains to arrange a marriage for the wife of a Torah scholar, especially to an ignoramus, for they will not succeed. "A vessel used for holy purposes should not be used for secular purposes."[1] This is not becoming to his

[A] Or: "bonded with him in the celestial Chashmal" — This alternate translation offers a more accessible rendering of the mystical concept while still preserving its technical nature. 'Bonded' might better capture the relationship implied by 'chatumah' in this context than 'sealed.'

[B] Or: "They interpreted the word "almanah" (widow) as a contraction of "al manah"" — This alternate translation more clearly indicates that the text is offering a folk etymology or wordplay on 'almanah' (widow), breaking it into 'al manah' to derive meaning from the component parts.

the groom with the bride') is recited. The author gives this a mystical interpretation related to the feminine presence.

[1] This is a halakhic principle being applied metaphorically to a Torah scholar's widow. The original

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The passage draws on the Zohar's eschatological vision to establish that the ultimate reward for righteous souls will include physical resurrection with special garments, collective gathering in Jerusalem, return to ancestral lands, and study of Torah in an elevated Land of Israel. | Cf. Genesis Rabbah, Chapter 70 — The midrash is cited to reinforce the concept that souls desire to be buried together with their loved ones, using the biblical example of Jacob's distress that Rachel would be buried separately from him. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat

garment, nor is his garment becoming to him, for "the leg of the master should not desire his sandal."[A]

פרק י׳

Chapter 10

כתוב בהלכות קבורה מתים ששונאים זה את זה אין לקוברם סמוכים ואמרי׳ כי מעשה בת״ח צדיק[i] שנקבר אצל אחד שאינו הגון ובא הצדיק בחלום לכל בני העיר והודיע להם צערו עד כי שמו אבנים בין קבר הצדיק לקבר הרשע במחיצה כי כשהצדיקים נחים על משכבותם מגלים להם רזי עליונים ותחתונים[ii] ואם נקבר אצלם אדם שאינו שוה במעלתם ימעטו העליונים מלגלות להם סודות שבהם יהנו כאלו יאכלו כל טוב. ורשב״י שאל קודם שיתן לריב״ל ליכנס אצלו אם נראתה הקשת בימיו[iii] כי היה

It is written in the laws of burial that those who hate each other should not be buried adjacent to one another. And we say that there was a case of a righteous Torah scholar who was buried next to someone who was unworthy, and the righteous man appeared in a dream to all the townspeople and made known his distress, until they placed stones between the grave of the righteous man and the grave of the wicked one as a partition. For when the righteous rest in their graves, heavenly and earthly mysteries are revealed to them, and if someone who is not of their spiritual stature is buried next to them, the heavenly powers will diminish the revelation of secrets[A] through which they would otherwise delight as if partaking of all goodness. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai inquired, before allowing Rabbi Joshua ben Levi to enter his presence, whether the rainbow had

[A] Or: "for even the rabbi's shoe would not fit his foot" — This idiomatic expression is challenging to translate literally while preserving its meaning. The alternate translation captures the intended meaning that the second husband is so incompatible with the Torah scholar's widow that even the deceased scholar's shoe wouldn't fit him—emphasizing their fundamental mismatch.

[A] Or: "the celestial beings will reduce their disclosure of mysteries" — This alternative emphasizes the active role of celestial beings rather than abstract 'powers' and may better reflect the kabbalistic worldview of the text, where specific angelic entities are thought to reveal mysteries to the righteous dead.

phrase 'kli she-nishtamesh bo kodesh al yishtamesh bo chol' is typically applied to Temple vessels, but here extends the concept of sanctity to marital relationships.

Vayechi — This Zohar reference supports the concept that souls maintain relationships in the afterlife and that proximity in burial reflects spiritual proximity in the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Sefer HaBahir — This kabbalistic text is cited to provide a mystical interpretation of male-female relationships, explaining that a woman represents the seventh of the divine forms that complete the human image. This serves to elevate the status of marriage by placing it within a cosmic, mystical framework. | Cf. Tractate Gittin — Although not explicitly named, this is a reference to the Talmudic teaching (Gittin 90b) that the altar weeps when someone divorces his first wife. The author uses this to reinforce the spiritual significance of the first marital bond as part of a divine union established in the supernal realm.

[i] The story of the righteous Torah scholar appearing in a dream is cited as proof for the prohibition against burying enemies together, demonstrating the Jewish belief that the dead retain awareness and can communicate with the living in dreams.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the souls of the righteous receive divine revelations in the afterlife. The quality of these revelations can be affected by neighboring graves, suggesting that spiritual conditions continue to matter after death.

[iii] According to Jewish mystical tradition, the rainbow's appearance indicates that the world needs divine protection from judgment. A completely righteous person in whose merit the world stands would not see a rainbow in his lifetime. Rabbi Shimon was checking Rabbi Joshua's spiritual level before sharing mystical secrets with him.

ירא פן ימעיטו לו הגדת הסודות עבור ריב״ל. ועיין בציוני פ׳ ויחי מזה: וחטוטי שכבי הוא צנור גדול[i] בדדרשו על והיה יד ה׳ בכם ובאבותיכם. וכן כתוב ביום ההוא יוציאו עצמות מלכי יהודה ושטחום לשמש וגו׳ כי היו מכוונים שלא יהיה להם מנוחה אפי׳ אחר המות ואולי גם לזה היתה כוונת חזקיה בגרירת עצמות אביו להציל נפשו מיד כף הקלע וספרו ממלכה אחת שתקנה מעצמות אויביה קוביאות. ומשניהם שהם י״ו מלמעלה וי״ו מלמטה תקנה לשחוק האי״שקקי כדי שלא יהיה להם מנוחה[ii] ואמרו על עצמות יהודה שהיו מגולגלים בארון וכמו שבעולם הזה יש סדר ההסבה כדאמרי׳ בגמרא בירושלמי מסכת תענית בזמן שהן שלש הגדול שבהן עולה ומסב בראש האמצעי וכו׳. כן יש לשמור הסדר הזה בקבורה דאמרי׳ בפ׳ בשלשה פרקים בירושלמי אמר שמואל בר רב יצחק אבות דרך הסבה הם

appeared in his days,[1] for he feared that the revelation of secrets might be diminished on account of Rabbi Joshua ben Levi. See the Tziyoni commentary on Parshat Vayechi regarding this matter.

The disturbance of graves is a great sin,[A] as they interpreted the verse "And the hand of the Lord will be against you and your ancestors." Similarly, it is written, "On that day they shall bring out the bones of the kings of Judah and spread them before the sun," for they intended that the deceased would have no rest even after death. Perhaps this was also Hezekiah's intention in dragging his father's bones—to save his soul from the sling of divine judgment.[B][2] And they told of a certain kingdom that fashioned dice from the bones of its enemies. And from both types of bones—sixteen from above and sixteen from below—they made chess pieces[3] so that the dead would have no rest. They said about the bones of Judah that they were rolled about in a coffin.

And just as in this world there is an order of reclining, as we say in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Ta'anit: "When there are three [dining], the greatest among them goes up and reclines at the head, the middle one [reclines next to him]," and so forth, similarly this order should be preserved in burial. As we say in chapter "In Three Periods" in the Jerusalem

[A] Or: "Disturbing the dead creates a major channel [for punishment]" — The Hebrew term 'צנור גדול' literally means 'great pipe/channel' and refers to creating a pathway for divine punishment to flow down to the living. This more literal translation preserves the metaphorical imagery while still conveying the severity.

[B] Or: "the hollow of the sling" — This is a more literal translation of the term 'kaf ha-kela' which refers to the hollow part of a sling used to hold the stone. In kabbalistic literature, it describes the soul's state of being cast about without rest after death, but the more literal translation preserves the biblical imagery.

[1] In Jewish mystical tradition, a completely righteous person would not see a rainbow in his lifetime, as the rainbow symbolizes God's covenant not to destroy the world again (Genesis 9:13-16). The absence of a rainbow would indicate that the merit of the righteous person alone was sufficient to protect the world from divine judgment.

[2] The 'kaf ha-kela' (כף הקלע) is a kabbalistic concept referring to a form of punishment for the soul after death, where it is cast about without rest. This is derived from the biblical phrase in 1 Samuel 25:29.

[3] The text uses 'האי״שקקי' (ha-ishkaki), which appears to be a medieval term for chess or a similar board game. The translation reflects the apparent intent of making game pieces from human bones as a form of posthumous desecration.

[i] The term 'צנור גדול' (great pipe/channel) metaphorically refers to a grave sin that creates a channel for punishment, showing the severity with which Judaism views disturbing the dead.

[ii] This refers to the medieval practice of making chess pieces (or similar game pieces) from bones. The text presents this as a deliberate act of posthumous cruelty, preventing the deceased from finding rest even after death.

קבורים:[ii] [i]

Talmud, Samuel son of Rav Isaac said: "The Patriarchs are buried in the manner of those who recline [at a meal]."[1] 45R

כשהיה המת מוחרם היו מרחיקין קברו מאחרים ח׳ אמות[iii] שלא יגע תבוסת קבר אחד שהוא ד״א בתבוסת חבירו ומצאתי כי המת שהיה בנדויו היו סוקלין את ארונו[iv] הטעם הוא כי כאשר הנסקל נקבר ברחוק כן המנודה והמצורע והוא גם כן כך בלפי מעלה עד בא זמנו אחר י״ב חדש[v] שעדיין כח הנפש והגוף קיים. ואמרו כי רוח המצורע וכן רוחו של מת מתפשטים כי בנים הנולדים בבית המצורע יש להם בקליפתם קצת סימנים משונים וזרע פשתן שיהיה בבית אשר שם מת אם יזרע לא יצמח בזרע

When a deceased person was under excommunication, they would distance his grave from others by eight cubits, so that the burial area of one grave, which is four cubits, would not touch the burial area of another. I found that when a person died while still under excommunication, they would stone his coffin. The reason is that just as one who is sentenced to stoning is buried at a distance, so too the excommunicated person and the leper are treated similarly, and this applies in the spiritual realms as well, until the appointed time after twelve months when the power of the soul and body still remains intact. 50R 55R

They said that the spirit of a leper, and likewise the spirit of a dead person, extends outward,[2] for children born in the house of a leper have in their outer form some unusual characteristics. Similarly, 60R

[1] This refers to the arrangement of the burial caves of the biblical Patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) and their wives in the Cave of Machpelah, suggesting they were positioned according to their honor and status, similar to formal dining arrangements.

[2] The Hebrew term 'מתפשטים' (mitpashtim) implies a spreading or extending influence beyond physical boundaries, suggesting that the spiritual condition of both lepers and the dead has effects that radiate outward to their surroundings.

[i] The comparison between burial arrangements and the seating order at formal meals reflects the Jewish concept of 'kavod ha-met' (honoring the dead), treating the deceased with the same dignity as the living.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The text references an incident from the Zohar where Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai (Rashbi) inquired about Rabbi Joshua ben Levi's worthiness before allowing him into his presence. The rainbow was considered a sign that the world needed protection from divine judgment, implying that a completely righteous person in whose merit the world stood would not see a rainbow in his lifetime. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — The author cites the Jerusalem Talmud regarding the proper order of reclining at a meal, using this as a basis for the arrangement of graves. This shows the Jewish principle of honoring the dead as one would honor the living, maintaining hierarchy and respect even in burial. | Cf. Book of Jeremiah 8:1-2 — The author uses this biblical reference to demonstrate the severe punishment of denying proper rest to the dead by disturbing their bones, presenting it as evidence for the importance of proper burial and rest for the deceased. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — The author alludes to the concept of kaf ha-kela (the sling of judgment), a kabbalistic concept of punishment for the soul after death where it is cast about without rest, derived from this biblical verse. | Cf. Tziyoni commentary on Parshat Vayechi — The author specifically directs readers to this commentary for more information on the mystical implications of burial arrangements, indicating that the proper separation of graves has spiritual significance beyond mere physical considerations.

[iii] Eight cubits, approximately 12-16 feet, representing a significant distance intended to create a spiritual and physical boundary between the excommunicated and the community.

[iv] The ritual of stoning the coffin symbolically extends the punishment of stoning (one of the four capital punishments in Jewish law) to someone who died while under excommunication, suggesting the severity of their unresolved status.

[v] The twelve-month period mentioned here is significant in Jewish tradition as the standard duration of mourning and also the time traditionally understood for the soul's judgment and initial purification after death.

פשתן אחר. ומי שמנודה לשמים ח״ו אפילו יעשה מעשים הגונים לא יועילו למעלה רק ח״ו יתנו חיות לקליפות[i] כי המעשים עולים ע״י טוב השרש המושרש אל האדם באדמה העליונה והמנודה נעקר ממלכות ויסוד ובינה[ii] ח״ו. והאדם בין בחייו בין במותו יש לו ד״א קרקע שכן כתיב והארץ נתן לבני אדם כי כמו שיש לנשמה למעלה מקום אם לטוב אם למוטב כן לגוף למטה בארץ וזה יהיה ד״א קרקע הכתובים בשטרות.[iii]

flax seed that was in a house where someone died, if planted, will not sprout like other flax seeds. And one who is excommunicated by Heaven, God forbid, even if he performs proper deeds, they will not benefit him in the higher realms,[A] but rather, God forbid, they will give vitality to the negative forces (kelipot).[1] This is because deeds ascend through the goodness of the root that is implanted in a person in the supernal earth,[B] and the excommunicated person is uprooted from the divine attributes of Malkhut, Yesod, and Binah, God forbid.

A person, both in life and in death, has four cubits of ground, as it is written: "The earth He has given to the children of men" (Psalms 115:16). For just as the soul has a place above, whether for good or for ill, so too the body has a place below in the earth, and this is the four cubits of land mentioned in legal documents.[2]

ובארבע אמות יוקפל בו כל

And in four cubits,[3] the entire world is folded

[A] Or: "And one who is under divine ban, God forbid, even if he performs righteous deeds, they will not ascend to the higher worlds" — This alternate translation emphasizes the concept of divine ban rather than excommunication, which might better reflect the distinction between human and divine rejection. It also uses 'higher worlds' instead of 'higher realms' to more directly reflect the kabbalistic cosmology implied in the text.

[B] Or: "This is because deeds ascend through the goodness of the soul-root that is anchored within a person in the celestial soil" — This alternate translation clarifies that 'השרש' (the root) likely refers to the soul's spiritual root or source, and 'אדמה העליונה' (supernal earth) refers to the celestial or divine realm from which souls originate according to kabbalistic thought.

[1] I've added the transliteration 'kelipot' to preserve the kabbalistic term, which lacks a perfect English equivalent. This concept is central to understanding the text's mystical framework regarding how spiritual energy is redirected when a person is in a state of excommunication.

[2] The reference to legal documents (שטרות) alludes to traditional Jewish legal contracts that sometimes specified a person's entitlement to four cubits of land, which was considered the minimum space needed for a person. This concept was applied both practically in life and symbolically in death.

[3] The Hebrew 'amot' (cubits) is a biblical measurement approximately 18-22 inches in length. Four cubits is traditionally considered the minimum personal space allotted to each individual.

[i] In Kabbalah, 'kelipot' (shells or husks) refer to the forces of spiritual impurity. The text suggests that the good deeds of an excommunicated person paradoxically strengthen these negative forces rather than elevating holiness.

[ii] These are three of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah. The text suggests that excommunication severs a person's connection to these divine attributes, which represent divine sovereignty (Malkhut), connection/foundation (Yesod), and understanding (Binah).

[iii] Cf. Psalms 115:16 — The author uses this verse to establish a parallel between the soul's place in the spiritual realm and the body's place in the physical world, specifically the four cubits of land that a person is entitled to for burial. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Sanhedrin 47a — The Talmudic passage discusses burial practices for those under ban (cherem), including placing a stone on the coffin of an excommunicated person who died without repentance, which is likely the source for the practice mentioned in this text. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Third Discourse, Chapter 2 — This section elaborates on themes introduced earlier in the work, particularly regarding how physical burial arrangements reflect and affect the soul's status in spiritual realms.

העולם כדאמרי׳ ביעקב קפל הקב״ה כל ארץ ישראל תחתיו וכן למעלה כל צדיק יש לו מדור ועולם בפני עצמו: ועל כן צריך לקבור כל מת בפני עצמו ויהיה לפחות בין עליון לתחתון ששה טפחים שהוא שעור עולם וקומה אחת. ומנהג בהרבה מקומות. לקבור הנהרגים בר מינן לבדם להיות כי תמיד תובעים דין עד כי ישפך דם הרוצח וזה שאמר הכתוב שופך דם האדם באדם דמו ישפך פי׳ בקטרוג שעושה נגדו אותו אדם שהרג גורם שפיכת דמו ואם לא בעולם הזה בעולם הבא כי הדם הוא הנפש כאשר הובא במדרש רבה פרשה ואתחנן ממעשה באשה אחת שבנה הרג אחיו ונטלה כוס מדמו ושמו תוך ארגז אחד ולעולם תסס עד כי נהרג גם אחיו. ולכן אין מלבישים אותם תכריכין רק כורכין סדין על בגדיהם למען לא יתבייש בפני שאר מתים ולא יראו להם החוצה הבגדי נקם שנוח לו לאותו הרוח להתלבש בם ואין לו נייחא להתלבש בריח מלבושים אחרים כשאר מתים להתראות לפני המלך המשפט בדמו התוסס עליהן ובתוכן וקול דמיו צועקים אליו מן האדמה ירא ה׳ וישפוט כדאמרי׳ בדמי נבות שלעולם תבעו דין על אחאב ואיזבל במקום שפיכתם. ואמרו כי סכין שנמצא בקבר הרוגים אין ליהנות ממנו. ועושים לנהרג נחת רוח כשמזכירין אותו לומר ה׳ ינקום דמו ברם אין למסור דין על שום אדם ושבקיה לרויא דמנפשיה נפיל אם ה׳ לא אנה לידו. ויען כי תמיד מתאוה להגביר כח הדין נגד הרוצח ואין

within him, as we say regarding Jacob that the Holy One, blessed be He, folded all the Land of Israel beneath him. Similarly, in the higher realms, each righteous person has their own dwelling place and world. Therefore, it is necessary to bury each deceased person separately, and there should be at least six handbreadths[1] between the upper and lower burial places, which is the measure of a world and one complete stature. It is the custom in many places to bury those who were killed (God forbid) separately, since they continually demand justice until the blood of their murderer is spilled. This is what Scripture means when it says, "Whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed"—meaning that through the accusation made against him by the person he killed, the murderer's blood is caused to be spilled, if not in this world, then in the World to Come. For blood is the soul, as brought in Midrash Rabbah, Parashat Va'etchanan, from a story about a woman whose son killed his brother. She took a cup of his blood and placed it in a chest, and it continued to bubble until her other son was also killed.

Therefore, we do not dress murder victims in burial shrouds, but rather wrap a sheet over their clothes so they will not be embarrassed before other deceased, and so that their garments of vengeance[2] will not be visible outside, as it is comfortable for that spirit to be clothed in them. The spirit finds no comfort in being clothed in the scent of other garments like other deceased, to appear before the King of Judgment with his blood bubbling upon and within them, and the voice of his blood crying out to Him from the ground: "May the Lord see and judge," as we say regarding Naboth's blood, which forever demanded justice against Ahab and Jezebel at the place of its spilling. And they said that a knife found in the grave of murder victims should not be used. We provide comfort to the murdered by mentioning them, saying, "May the Lord avenge his blood." However, one should not deliver judgment against any person; rather, "leave the drunkard alone, for he will fall on his own"[3] if

[1] A 'tefach' (handbreadth) is approximately 3-4 inches. Six handbreadths would be about 18-24 inches of separation between graves stacked vertically.

[2] The Hebrew 'bigdei nakam' (garments of vengeance) refers to the blood-stained clothes of murder victims, which are understood metaphysically as evidence that will testify against the murderer in the divine court.

[3] This is a Talmudic saying (shavkei le-ravya d'mi-nafshei nafil) advising against interfering with

לנפשו נייחא עד יהרג או ימות
כי שם יחדו למשפט יקרבו או עד
שיגיע עת פקודתו שהיה לו מן
העולם כי אז נתן רשות לדומה
להכניסו במספר שוכני עפר
כדאמרי׳ במסכת חגיגה פ״א
דאמר מלאך המות לרב ביבי בר
אביי שהמתים קודם זמנם משום
ויש נספה בלא משפט רעינא
להו אנא עד דמלו לדרא והדר
משלימנא להו לדומה ופי׳ רש״י
אינו מוסרם לשומר המתים ששמו
דומה אלא מגלגלים עמו ושטין
בעולם עד שיתמלא שנותם. על
כן מנהג כשר להרחיקו משאר
מתים למען לא יעות אדם בריבו.
ועיין בחלק רביעי שני פרקים
מיוחדים לדרוש זה. ובירית
ברותה שאין העולם מתיסר
בשופכי דמים אלא נמחים מן
הארץ כל עוד שלא ישובו וזה
לפי שאין הקטיגור נעשה סניגור.
ויש מי שכתב שאדם אחד שהיה
מנודה בהסכמת הקהל אם חלה
לא ברכוהו אותו כי בברכה
נמצאו היו מתירים החרם והיה
צריך הסכמת הקהל. וטעם שהיו
נותנים אבן על ארון המוחרם
אולי יורה כי הגביר עליו כח
היצר הרע שהוא אבן נגף וצור
מכשול [i]

the Lord has not delivered him into his hand.

Since the soul of the murdered always desires to strengthen the power of judgment against the murderer and finds no rest until he is killed or dies, they will approach judgment together, or until the time of his appointed end in the world arrives. Then permission is given to Dumah to include him among the dwellers of dust, as we say in Tractate Chagigah, chapter 1, where the Angel of Death said to Rav Bibi bar Abaye that those who die before their time, as it says, "There are those who perish without justice," "I tend to them until their generation is complete, and then I deliver them to Dumah." Rashi explains: "He does not deliver them to the guardian of the dead, whose name is Dumah, but rather they roll with him and wander in the world until their years are completed." Therefore, it is a proper custom to distance the murdered from other deceased so that no one will be corrupted in his dispute.

See the fourth section, two special chapters that expound on this. There is a covenant that the world is not punished by bloodshedders; rather, they are erased from the earth as long as they do not repent, because "the prosecutor does not become the defender."[1] There are those who wrote that if a person who was excommunicated by consent of the community became ill, they would not bless him, because through blessing they would be releasing the ban, which required the community's consent. The reason they would place a stone on the coffin of the excommunicated was perhaps to indicate that the power of

someone who is self-destructive, as they will face natural consequences. Here it's applied to murderers who will face divine justice without human intervention.

[1] This is a principle in Jewish law that something associated with sin cannot be used for holy purposes. In this context, it explains why murderers cannot attain atonement easily—the very blood they've spilled testifies against them.

[i] Cf. Midrash Rabbah, Parashat Va'etchanan — The text cites this midrash to support the notion that the blood of murder victims continues to 'cry out' for justice. The specific story referenced about a woman collecting her murdered son's blood in a cup illustrates the Jewish belief that spilled blood maintains a metaphysical presence and demands retribution. | Cf. Genesis 9:6 — The author reinterprets this biblical verse in a mystical way, suggesting that it's not merely a legal prescription for capital punishment, but describes a metaphysical reality where the murdered person's soul actively prosecutes the murderer in the divine court. | Cf. Story of Naboth's vineyard (1 Kings 21) — This biblical reference reinforces the Jewish concept that innocent blood continues to 'cry out' for justice, even after death. The author uses this well-known biblical story to support the special burial practices for murder victims. | Cf. Tractate Chagigah, Chapter 1 — The citation from Talmudic literature provides authority for the belief that souls of those who die prematurely have a different afterlife experience than those who complete their natural lifespan, which relates to the author's discussion of murdered souls. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fourth Section — The author refers readers to another section of his own work for further elaboration on the topic of murdered

the evil inclination, which is a stumbling stone and rock of offense,[1] had prevailed over him.

וזה גרם לו בחינת עץ הרע
שממנו נעשה הארון כמו שאמרו
במדרש על פסוק בתוך עץ הגן
אמר ר׳ לוי רמז לתולדותיו
שיהיו נתונין בארונות של עץ
כמו שאדם הראשון נתחבא
מתוך אותו עץ מאימת השכינה
ומיתתו היתה כפרה לגופו ולכן
היו סוקלין ארונו כי יצר הרע
שבו היו ראוי לרצועה ורידוי
ובזה מתבזה בין החיים וכפרה
היתה היא לו וכן גרירת עצמות
שבתוכה רוח חיות מה בנדרש
למעלה בפ״ו הוא כפרה לנפש
שבזה אינה מגולגלת ומקולעת
בתוך כף הקלע אחר כי קבל
ענשה בעולם הזה כי שחה לעפר
נפשה וכמים הנגרים ארצה כן
נתנו בעפר פיה שהוא חיות מה
שבעצמות ובזה יש לה תקוה כי
יפה שעה בתשובה בעולם הזה: [i]

This was caused by the nature of the evil tree[A] from which the coffin was made, as they said in the Midrash on the verse "in the midst of the tree of the garden" (Genesis 3:8): Rabbi Levi said,[2] "It alludes to his descendants, that they would be placed in wooden coffins, just as the first man hid himself among that tree out of fear of the Divine Presence." And his death was an atonement for his body. Therefore, they would stone his coffin, for the evil inclination within him deserved the lash and subjugation, and in this way he was disgraced among the living, and it served as atonement for him. Similarly, the dragging of bones in which there remains some vital spirit,[B] as explained above in Chapter 6, is an atonement for the soul, as through this it is not made to wander and be slung within the "hollow of the sling" after it has received its punishment in this world. For "its soul has bowed down to the dust"[C] (Psalms 44:26), and like water spilled on the ground, they have placed in the dust its "mouth," which is the vitality that remains in the

160R 165R 170R 175R

[A] Or: "the aspect of the evil tree" — The Hebrew term 'bechinat' often refers to a specific aspect or quality rather than nature in general. This alternative might better capture the kabbalistic nuance of the term as referring to a specific manifestation or aspect of evil.

[B] Or: "a certain vital spirit" — The Hebrew 'mah' here could be translated more literally as 'a certain' rather than 'some,' which might better reflect the author's specificity about this spiritual essence.

[C] Or: "its soul is brought low to the dust" — This alternative might better express the passive nature implied in the Hebrew, suggesting the soul is forcibly brought low rather than voluntarily bowing.

[1] This phrase ('even negef v'tzur michshol') comes from Isaiah 8:14, where it refers to divine judgment. Here it is used metaphorically to describe the evil inclination (yetzer hara) that overcame the excommunicated person.

[2] This appears to be from Bereshit Rabbah, the classical midrashic collection on Genesis, where Rabbi Levi offers this interpretation connecting Adam's hiding among trees to human burial in wooden coffins.

souls, showing how Ma'avar Yabok was designed with internal cross-references to guide readers through related topics across different sections.

[i] Cf. Genesis 3:8 — The author draws a parallel between Adam hiding among the trees out of fear after sinning and human bodies being placed in wooden coffins after death, suggesting that coffins symbolize our mortality resulting from original sin. | Cf. Psalms 44:26 — The author uses this verse to describe the soul's state of degradation and punishment, connecting physical burial with spiritual humiliation as part of the process of atonement. | Cf. 1 Samuel 25:29 — The author inverts this concept to describe a form of punishment for souls, where instead of being bound in the 'bundle of life' with God, unrepentant souls are cast about in a 'sling,' representing spiritual torment and instability after death. | Cf. Avot 4:17 — The author concludes with this rabbinic principle to emphasize that even for someone who has been excommunicated or severely punished, genuine repentance in this world offers hope for spiritual redemption, as physical punishment can

bones.[1] In this, there is hope for it, for a moment of repentance in this world is more beautiful [than all the life of the World to Come].[2] 180R

פרק י״א

מי שמת לו בנו או בתו אל ינשק אותם גם שמצינו נשיקה מהבן לאב ביוסף וכ״כ במדרש רבה פ׳ ע׳ ארבע נשיקות הן וכו׳. ובפ׳ כ״ה על פסוק גשה נא ושקה לי בני א״ל אתה נושקני בקבורה. ואין אחר נושקני בקבורה וכתוב בספר צרור המור מכאן אמרו זו נשיקת פרישות ואמר מכאן שצריך אדם לנשק את מתו על פרישתו. מ״מ בנו או בתו שאני[i] ע״ד שאמרו קצת מן החכמים שאין לאב לילך אחר בנו הבכור לקבורתו גם שאין הדין ולא המנהג כן וכן אל יניח אשתו לנשוק אותם כי מקצרים ימי בניהם ואולי כי דבקות רוח האב ואם פומא בפומא או בכל מקום שידבקו הבלם בבנם או בבתם המתים זה גורם כי נפשות הבנים שהם בבחם ומכחם מורישים להם נפש החיונית כאשר הצענו למעלה וכן הרשימו מאותם שמכבר הולידו מתדבק בכח המיתה עלמא דנוקבא[ii] ובזה מקצרים ימי בניהם או בנותיהם. וכן אין לומר למתו שמוטל לפניו שיבא ליטול אותו וכ״ש שאין לתפוס

Chapter 11

A person whose son or daughter has died should not kiss them, even though we find instances of a son kissing a father, as with Joseph. Similarly, in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 70, it states "There are four types of kisses, etc." And in chapter 25, regarding the verse "Come near and kiss me, my son," he said to him, "You are kissing me in burial, but no one else will kiss me in burial." It is written in the book Tzeror HaMor, "From here they said this is the kiss of separation," and further, "From here we learn that one should kiss their deceased at their departure." Nevertheless, a son or daughter is different, as some of the sages have said that a father should not follow his firstborn son to burial, even though this is neither the law nor the custom. Similarly, one should not allow his wife to kiss them, for this shortens the lives of their other children. Perhaps this is because the attachment of the spirit of the father and mother—whether mouth to mouth or in any place where their breath clings to their dead son or daughter—causes the souls of the children, which are from their power and strength, to bequeath to them the vital life-force, as we have explained above. Likewise, the residual spiritual impression from those they have already brought into the world attaches to the power of death, the feminine realm, and thereby shortens the days of their sons or daughters. 5R 10R 15R 20R 25R

One should also not say to their deceased lying before them, "Come and take me," and certainly one

[1] This is a difficult passage to translate literally. The author appears to be making a wordplay between 'peh' (mouth) and a spiritual 'opening' or essence within the bones that contains residual vitality after death.

[2] I've added the bracketed text to complete the rabbinic saying that is being referenced here, which is from Pirkei Avot 4:17: 'Better is one hour of repentance and good deeds in this world than all the life of the World to Come.'

serve as atonement. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 6 — The author refers back to his own earlier explanation about a spiritual essence that remains in human bones even after death, connecting this to both physical burial practices and the metaphysical state of the soul after death.

[i] The author distinguishes between different types of family relationships regarding mourning practices, suggesting that the parent-child relationship has unique spiritual considerations.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that death belongs to the feminine realm (Malkhut), which can exert a dangerous influence when living parents connect too intimately with their deceased children.

ידו בידו ולומר שיוליך אותו אחריו דתפיסת יד גורם חיבור ואמונה עם הב׳ הנתפסין ומעלין עליו כאלו הרג את עצמו[i] דניחא למיתי במיתת קרוביהם החיים וגם שאבוה דשמואל הוה בכי ואמר משום דלעגלא אתית לן אפשר דהוה בכי על צערא דבניה או משום תורה ומצות דלא הוה אפשר לבנו לקיים עוד בעה״ז ובזה הוה נפיש זכותא דידיה דאבוה. וכבר אמרנו ששומעים מה שנאמר להם[ii] וכתיב אך את דמכם לנפשותיכם אדרוש ועוד כי לעולם לא יפתח אדם פיו לשטן.[iii] ובפרט בעת ובמקום שנתן לו רשות וספרו מאשה אחת שהניח ידי בניה החיים ע״י בניה שמתו ומתו גם הם. ובתקון כ״ג א״ר אליעזר יומא חד הוה אזלינא אנא ורבי יוסי ואתא בריה דרב המנונא סבא מההוא עלמא בדיוקנא דהאי עלמא ואזדמן לי באורחא בגוונא דחמר בתרין חמרין. וראיה מכמה סבין שהיו באים לגלות סתרי תורה לר״ש בן יוחאי בזהר והרבה פעמים מצינו זה בתקונים שהיו מנשמות הצדיקים שהם במתיבתא דרקיעא ומתיבתא עילאה.[iv] כתב רבינו ירוחם בשם ר׳ יהודה החסיד שאין לחצוב קבר למת בר מינן אא״כ רוצים לקברו בו לאלתר.[v] וכבר אמרנו שלא יפתח אדם פה לשטן שכוונתם שלא יגרום אדם לשטן שיפתח פיו בקללת עצמו או אחרים כי פעמים השטן פותח פיו עמו ונוטל קללתו ומאשר

should not grasp the hand of the deceased in their own hand and say that the deceased should lead them after him, for grasping hands creates a connection and bond between the two who are joined, and it is considered as if one has killed oneself, since the dead are pleased with the death of their living relatives. Also, though Samuel's father wept and said, "For you have come to us quickly," it is possible that he was weeping over his son's suffering, or because of the Torah and commandments that his son would no longer be able to fulfill in this world, and thereby the merit of the father would increase.

We have already stated that the dead hear what is said to them, and it is written, "However, I will require an accounting for your lifeblood," and furthermore, a person should never open their mouth to Satan, especially at a time and place where permission has been given to him. There is a story about a woman who placed the hands of her living children in the hands of her dead children, and they too died. In Tikkun 23, Rabbi Eliezer said, "One day I was walking with Rabbi Yosi when the son of Rav Hamnuna the Elder came from that world in the form of this world and appeared to me on the road as a donkey between two donkeys." And there is evidence from many elders who came to reveal secrets of Torah to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai in the Zohar, and we find this many times in the Tikkunim, that they were from the souls of the righteous who are in the heavenly academy and the supernal academy.

Rabbeinu Yerucham wrote in the name of Rabbi Judah the Pious that one should not dig a grave for the dead (God forbid) unless they intend to bury him in it immediately. We have already said that a person should not open their mouth to Satan, meaning that a person should not cause Satan to open his mouth with curses against oneself or others, because sometimes Satan opens his mouth along with the person, takes his curse, confirms it, and says, "So-and-so has

[i] The text considers symbolic actions with the dead as potentially equivalent to suicide, showing how seriously these prohibitions were taken.

[ii] The author affirms the belief that the deceased remain aware and can hear what the living say to them, which explains why certain statements to them are prohibited.

[iii] This is a rabbinic principle warning against speaking of potential misfortunes, as such speech might invite these misfortunes to occur.

[iv] The text describes a sophisticated cosmology where righteous souls continue their Torah study in heavenly academies and can sometimes return to reveal wisdom to the living.

[v] This prohibition against preparing graves in advance reflects concern that such actions might hasten a person's death, demonstrating how physical actions were believed to have metaphysical consequences.

אותה ואומר פלוני כן דן דינו
70 הוא בעצמו והודאת בעל דין
כמאה עדים וגם שבב״ד של
מטה אין אדם משים עצמו רשע,
ב״ד של מעלה שאני כדאמר
בהקדמת הזהר שאמר דומה נגד
75 דוד טרונייא אית לי עליה דאמר
חי ה׳ כי בן מות הוא. ואמרו כי
קודם דינו של אדם הוא מודה על
כל חטאיו ודן דיניה כי האל לא
יעות משפט וכשבעל כנפים מגיד
80 וממשיך אליו הדבר והקללה
שקלל אדם עצמו אז כתיב ואל
תאמר לפני המלאך כי שגגה היא
וכן אמרו כי המשבר כליו בחמתו
מקריב קרבן לשטן ח״ו אשרי
85 הסותם פי שטן במעשיו לבל יהיה
לו פה לקטרג. ואמרו דורשי
רשומות כי ביטול הקליפות הוא
חיזוק שרשיהן ולכן בשבת שעת
המנחה מתגלה מצח הרצון שהם
90 שרשי הדינין שהומתקו למטה
אז בעת שליטתם בסוד הנהגת
שבת וסוספיתא דדהבא למטה
מטה כבר נשקע מע״ש בנוקבא
דתהומא רבה והאי ארעא חציפא
95 דכל טובא דעלמא מתבלי בה
ותדיק ותסיף כלא והיא מאכלו
של נחש עקלתון. על כן בלילה
דביה כלבין נבחין כי נתרים
ממאסרם וחמורים משלשוליהון
100 ומתפשטים להנהיג בתחתונים
הדינין שקבלה המלכות בתפלת
המנחה ובו תרמוש כל חיתו יער
שהם בחות התחתונים למטה
מעולם של סנדלפון לא יפתח
105 אדם פי הארץ אם לא יסתום
הגולל מיד פן ח״ו באות נפשה
תשאף רוח על ידי הפרא הלמוד
מדבר. ובשם ר״י החסיד כתבו
שטוב לקבור תרנגול הנקרא גבר
110 בקבר ריקם אולי בזה מחליש
ומטמין כח הדין המושפע מצד
מלאך גבריאל הנקרא גבר לבל
יעיר חמתו. ועוד כראות באות
הטומאה קבר פתוח בלילה
115 מוצאים מקום לקטרג ופעמים יש
נספה בלא משפט. כאמרם הות

thus judged himself," and the admission of a litigant
is like a hundred witnesses. And although in the 70R
earthly court a person cannot incriminate himself,
the heavenly court is different, as it says in the in-
troduction to the Zohar that Dumah said against
David, "I have a complaint against him, for he said,
'As the Lord lives, he is worthy of death.'" And they 75R
said that before a person's judgment, he confesses all
his sins and judges himself, for God does not pervert
justice. And when the winged being reveals and ex-
tends to him the matter and the curse with which a
person cursed himself, then it is written, "Do not say 80R
before the angel that it was an error." Similarly, they
said that one who breaks his vessels in anger offers
a sacrifice to Satan (God forbid). Blessed is the one
who stops Satan's mouth through his actions so that
Satan will have no opening to accuse. 85R

The interpreters of allusions have said that
nullifying the external forces strengthens their
roots. Therefore, on the Sabbath at the time of
the afternoon prayer, the forehead of divine will
is revealed—these are the roots of judgments that 90R
have been sweetened below. Then, at the time of
their dominion, according to the mystery of Sabbath
governance, the dregs of gold far below have already
sunk from Sabbath eve into the opening of the
great abyss. This is the insolent earth in which all 95R
the goodness of the world wears away, is crushed,
and comes to an end, and it is the food of the
twisted serpent. Therefore, at night when dogs
bark, for they are released from their confinement
and donkeys from their chains, and the powers of 100R
judgment received by Malkhut during the afternoon
prayer spread to govern the lower realms, when "all
the beasts of the forest creep about"—these are the
lower powers beneath the world of Sandalphon—a
person should not open the mouth of the earth if 105R
he does not immediately seal the grave, lest, God
forbid, through the opening, its soul draws in the
spirit by means of the wild beast that learns to
speak.

In the name of Rabbi Judah the Pious, they 110R
wrote that it is good to bury a rooster, called "gever"
(man), in an empty grave, perhaps to weaken and
conceal the power of judgment that flows from the
angel Gabriel, who is called "gever," so that his
wrath will not be aroused. Furthermore, when the 115R
forces of impurity see an open grave at night, they

כשגגה היוצאת.[i] ברם לעולם דין אמת וכל דרכיו משפט:[ii]

find an opportunity to accuse, and sometimes "there is one who is swept away without justice," as they said, "It was like an inadvertent sin that proceeds from the ruler." Nevertheless, true judgment is eternal, and all His ways are just. 120R

פרק י״ב

Chapter 12

ממה שאנו רואים כמה פעמים בני אדם בריאים והם מתים מיתה פתאומית[iii] זה מורה דבקותו יתברך עמנו ע״י הנשמה ולכן מסלקה כל זמן שרוצה. וילבש האדם חרדה במיתת בניו בחשבו כי בכנפיו נמצאו דם נפשות האביונים נקיים[iv] ועונו גרם שנעשקו בירידתם[v] על כי תיקלא לא קיימא באשלמותא[vi] ומכרעת

From what we observe, when healthy people sometimes die suddenly, this demonstrates God's attachment to us through the soul,[A 1] which He withdraws whenever He wishes. A person should be struck with trembling at the death of his children, considering 5R that on his wings may be found the blood of innocent needy souls, and that his sin caused them to be wronged in their descent to earth because the scale was not perfectly balanced[B 2] and tipped toward guilt—especially on weekdays if it is not the 10R

[A] Or: "by means of the divine soul implanted within us" — This alternate translation emphasizes the kabbalistic understanding that the soul is a divine element placed within humans, not merely a component of human existence.

[B] Or: "the cosmic scales did not maintain perfect equilibrium" — This alternative captures more of the kabbalistic cosmological implications of the metaphor, emphasizing the divine scales that weigh judgment and mercy rather than mundane scales.

[1] The Hebrew term 'דבקותו' (devekuto) has stronger connotations than mere 'attachment'—it implies an intimate divine connection or cleaving to the human soul.

[2] This is a translation of 'תיקלא לא קיימא באשלמותא,' a kabbalistic expression referring to cosmic scales of judgment and mercy being out of balance.

[i] This alludes to Ecclesiastes 10:5, referring to errors that proceed from rulers, here applied to premature deaths caused by improper actions around burial.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 50:1 — Referenced to show a biblical precedent of kissing the dead, though specifically a son kissing a father rather than parent kissing child, which the text prohibits. | Cf. Genesis 27:26 — Cited to show a father (Isaac) being kissed by his son (Jacob), supporting the pattern that children may kiss parents but not vice versa. | Cf. Sefer Tzeror HaMor — Used to establish the concept of a 'kiss of separation' or farewell to the deceased, while still maintaining the prohibition for parents kissing their deceased children. | Cf. Genesis 9:5 — Used to warn against actions that might endanger one's life, including symbolic gestures with the dead that might 'invite death'. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 23 — Cited to demonstrate that souls from the afterlife can manifest in this world, explaining why certain precautions around the dead are necessary. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 10:5 — Used to explain how death can sometimes occur prematurely or unjustly when negative spiritual forces gain an opportunity through improper burial practices. | Cf. Psalm 145:17 — Concluding statement affirming divine justice despite the seemingly harsh spiritual dangers described, providing theological context for the prohibitions.

[iii] This refers to sudden death without warning or apparent illness, which the author interprets as a direct divine act rather than a natural occurrence. This reflects the theological perspective that even seemingly random deaths are purposeful expressions of God's will.

[iv] This metaphorical expression draws on biblical imagery (Jeremiah 2:34) where blood on one's garments symbolizes guilt for the deaths of innocents. Here it suggests parental responsibility for the spiritual welfare of their children's souls.

[v] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that souls are 'sent down' to earth for incarnation, and that the spiritual condition of the parents affects the quality of the soul's descent and embodiment.

[vi] Literally 'the scale does not stand in perfection,' a kabbalistic metaphor for the balance of cosmic forces of judgment and mercy being disrupted, causing judgment to predominate.

לצד החובה ובפרט בחול אם אינו ליל טבילה[i] כדדרשו בזהר על פסוק ואין ברגלים חוטא דמבעי ליה לאיניש לאנפא לקדושא דמריה ליל שבת ולמימר פסוקי דאתערותא כגון רוח ה׳ אלהים וגו׳ עם מה שכתוב בזהר פ׳ ויקרא. ואמרו כי הורדת דמעות על אדם כשר מציל בניו של אדם ממות[ii] כי בזהר פ׳ אחרי מות דף רנ״ז כתיב כל המצטער על אבודיהון דצדיקייא או אחית דמעין עליהו קב״ה אכריז עליה וסר עונך וחטאתך תכופר ולא עוד אלא דלא ימותון בנוהי בחיוהי. והורדת הדמעה גורם מיתוק הדינים[iii] כדאמרי׳ במדרש איכה על מאמר שאמר הקב״ה למטטרו״ן אם אי אתה מניח לי וכו׳ אבנס למקום שאין לך רשות ליכנס וגו׳ וכן הפסוק אומר ויקרא ה׳ אלהים צבאות ביום ההוא לבכי ולמספד שהכל היה למתוק הדין בהורדת טיפי רוגז חוצה. ובזהר בפ׳ שמות דף י״ט ע״ב אמרו בעשרה כתרי מלכא אית תרין דמעין[iv] והן שתי מדות [v]

night of ritual immersion, as they interpreted in the Zohar regarding the verse "he who hastens with his feet sins," meaning that one should prepare for the sanctification of his Master on Sabbath eve and recite verses of spiritual awakening,[1] such as "The spirit of the Lord God..." along with what is written in the Zohar, Parashat Vayikra. 15R

They said that shedding tears for a worthy person saves one's children from death, for in the Zohar, Parashat Acharei Mot, page 257, it is written: "Whoever grieves over the loss of the righteous or sheds tears for them—the Holy One, blessed be He, proclaims about him: 'Your iniquity is taken away, and your sin is atoned for,' and moreover, his children will not die during his lifetime." The shedding of tears causes the sweetening of judgments,[A] as stated in Midrash Eichah regarding the passage where the Holy One, blessed be He, said to Metatron: "If you do not permit Me... I will enter a place where you have no permission to enter," etc. Similarly, the verse states: "And the Lord God of hosts called on that day for weeping and mourning"—all of this was to sweeten judgment by releasing drops of wrath outward.[2] And in the Zohar, Parashat Shemot, page 19b, they said: "Among the ten crowns of the King there are two tears, which are two attributes [of judgment]." 20R 25R 30R 35R

[A] Or: "tempering of the divine severity" — This alternate translation might be clearer for readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology, as 'sweetening' in English doesn't immediately convey the concept of transforming harsh judgment into mercy.

[1] The term 'דאתערותא' (de-it'aruta) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to 'awakening from below'—human-initiated spiritual activity that stimulates divine response.

[2] The Hebrew 'הורדת טיפי רוגז חוצה' is a technical kabbalistic concept describing how tears externalize divine judgment, preventing it from manifesting in more harmful ways.

[i] This refers to the prohibition against marital relations on regular weekdays unless it is the wife's night for ritual immersion after her menstrual period. The author suggests that conception at inappropriate times creates spiritual imbalances.

[ii] This presents a theological principle that sincere grief expressed for the righteous creates protective merit that shields one's children from death—establishing a mystical cause-and-effect relationship between emotional expression and divine protection.

[iii] A fundamental kabbalistic concept meaning 'sweetening of judgments,' where harsh divine judgments are transformed into mercy through specific spiritual practices—in this case, through genuine tears of grief.

[iv] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) containing two 'tears' that represent attributes of judgment. The shedding of human tears is believed to affect these cosmic 'tears' of judgment.

[v] Cf. Zohar, Acharei Mot — The text is using this reference to explain the spiritual benefit of mourning properly for the righteous. It establishes a theological principle that genuine grief ex-

דין שהדין בא משתיהן כד״א
שתים הנה קוראותיך וכשהקב״ה
זוכר את בניו הוא מוריד אותם
לים הגדול שהוא ים החכמה
להמתיקן והופך מדת הדין
למדת רחמים ומרחם עליהם
וא״ר יהודה נקראים שתי דמעות
שמהן באים דמעות מהן בא
הדין.[i] מצאתי יש בנ״א שכל
הנקרא על שמו יחיו ויהיו בניו
קיימים ויעמידו תולדות כדכתיב
כן יעמוד זרעכם ושמכם. ויש כל
אלו להם להפך דכתיב והנחתם
שמכם לשבועה לבחירי וכתיב
ולא שם לו על פני חוץ וכתיב
אשר שם שמות בארץ אל תקרי
שמות אלא שמות לשון שממון
שגורם השם ההוא.[ii] ולכן אמרו
דלא מסקינן בשמייהו של רשעים
כיון שהיה בית יד לטומאה וכל
הכלים צריך להגעיל ידותיהן
כמותן ולכן טוב ליזהר מזה
וכיוצא בזה בתרי הויא חזקה
כדאיפסקא ביבמות הלכתא
כרבי במקום סכנה.[iii] ואמרו
ג״כ כי יש נשים שאין לישא

The judgment comes from both of these [tears], as it is said, "These two things have befallen you" (Isaiah 51:19).[A] When the Holy One, blessed be He, remembers His children, He lowers these [tears] into the great sea, which is the sea of Wisdom, to sweeten them, and transforms the attribute of Judgment into the attribute of Mercy, and has compassion upon them. And Rabbi Yehudah said: They are called two tears because from them come tears, and from them comes judgment.[1]

I have found that there are people whose namesakes will live, whose children will endure, and who will establish generations, as it is written, "So shall your seed and your name endure" (Isaiah 66:22). And there are those for whom the opposite is true, as it is written, "And you shall leave your name as a curse unto My chosen ones" (Isaiah 65:15), and it is written, "He has no name on the face of the earth" (Job 18:17), and it is written, "Who has set desolations in the earth" (Psalms 46:9)—do not read "shamot" (desolations) but "shemot" (names),[B] meaning desolation caused by that name. Therefore, they said that we do not use the names of the wicked, since such a name was a handle for impurity, and all vessels require purification of their handles as well. Therefore, it is good to be

[A] Or: "as the verse states, "These two things have happened to you" (Isaiah 51:19)" — This alternative translation uses more common English phrasing and may be clearer for readers unfamiliar with biblical language.

[B] Or: "do not read it as "shamot" (desolations) but as "shemot" (names)" — This alternative more clearly conveys the rabbinic wordplay between two similar Hebrew words that differ only in vocalization.

[1] The Hebrew uses a play on words connecting 'tears' (דמעות/dema'ot) with 'judgment' (דין/din), suggesting an etymological or spiritual connection that isn't fully captured in translation.

pressed for others creates spiritual merit that offers protection to one's own family members. | Cf. Midrash Eichah — This reference establishes the concept that tears have cosmic power to mitigate divine judgment. The dialogue between God and Metatron illustrates the principle that expressions of grief create channels for divine mercy to flow into realms otherwise dominated by judgment. | Cf. Zohar, Vayikra — This reference connects to practices for sanctifying the Sabbath through recitation of awakening verses. The author uses this to explain that improper preparation for sacred times can contribute to spiritual imbalances that might affect one's children. | Cf. Zohar, Shemot 19b — This reference explains the kabbalistic concept of divine tears as attributes of judgment that can be sweetened through human tears of compassion. It establishes a mystical correspondence between human emotional expression and cosmic processes.

[i] The text establishes a kabbalistic connection between tears and divine judgment, suggesting that the same celestial source produces both emotional response (tears) and cosmic justice (judgment).

[ii] The author employs the rabbinic interpretive technique of 'al tikrei' (read not X but Y) to connect the Hebrew words 'shemot' (names) and 'shamot' (desolations), suggesting that certain names can bring spiritual desolation.

[iii] This reference to Talmudic law (from Yevamot) establishes that in matters of potential spiritual danger, like harmful names, one should follow the stricter opinion.

אותן כי לא יצליחו שלהיותן
מעלמא דנוקבא שרגליה יורדות
מות[i] ביון שמתחילות להטות
עצמן לצד חוצה אין לך מזיק
גדול מהן ואמרו כמה רעה אשה
רעה שהיא מר ממות וגם אם אינה
רעה במעשיה אם הורע מזלה
חוטא ילכד בה ולכן יש דין
קטלנית באשה ולא באיש[ii] ועיין
בסבא וכבר אמרו בית תינוק
ואשה אם אין נחש יש סימן. אשה
טובה בחיק ירא אלהים תנתן
להניח ברכה אל ביתו כי היא
מוכנת לקבלה להיותה כלי.
ואמרו כי מי שהוא עצרן וקפדן
לא ירויחו אחרים בממונו שאין
פרוטתו מתברכת כי נותן בעין
רעה. וכבר העמידנו בזה המלך
החכם באומרו אל תלחם את
לחם רע עין וגו׳ פתך אכלת
תקיאנה. ושמת סכין בלועך אם
בעל נפש אתה. שלהיותו מצד
כח הדינים המגלדים ועוצרים
השפע שעליהם כתוב לפני קרתו
מי יעמוד המקבל ממנו מטה
אשורו מני דרך ועוזב מקור מים
חיים לחצוב לו בורות נשברים
כי אולי אם ישא אל אלוה פניו
ומתכא דרחמנא יאכל צנור
נשמתו יהיה יותר מוכן לקבל
בעין יפה. ובזהר פ׳ שמות דף ג׳
ר׳ חייא פתח אל תלחם את לחם
רע עין ואל תתאו למטעמותיו
אל תלחם את לחם רע עין בגין

cautious about this, and similarly in other cases, two occurrences establish a presumption, as was ruled in Yevamot: "The law follows Rabbi [Yehudah HaNasi] in cases of danger."[1]

They also said that there are women whom one should not marry because they will not bring success, for being from the feminine realm whose "feet descend to death" (Proverbs 5:5), once they begin to incline themselves toward the external side, there is no greater harmful entity than they. And they said, "How evil is an evil woman, for she is more bitter than death" (Ecclesiastes 7:26). Even if she is not evil in her deeds, if her destiny (mazal) is bad, "the sinner will be caught by her" (Ecclesiastes 7:26). Therefore, the law of the "deadly wife" (katlanit) applies to a woman but not to a man. See the Sabba [section of the Zohar], and they have already said, "A house, a child, and a woman—if there is no snake, there is a sign."[2]

A good woman will be given into the bosom of one who fears God, to bring blessing to his house, for she is prepared to receive it, being a vessel [for divine blessing]. And they said that one who is miserly and particular[A] will not benefit others with his wealth, for his coin is not blessed, as he gives with an evil eye. The wise king has already taught us this, saying, "Do not eat the bread of one who has an evil eye, etc." (Proverbs 23:6), "The morsel you have eaten, you will vomit up" (Proverbs 23:8), "And put a knife to your throat if you are a person of appetite" (Proverbs 23:2). Because he is influenced by congealing judgmental forces that restrict the flow, concerning which it is written, "Who can stand before His cold?" (Psalms 147:17). One who receives from him

[A] Or: "who is stingy and irritable" — This alternative better captures the emotional quality implied in the original Hebrew terms, which describe not just frugality but a negative personality trait.

[1] The Hebrew term for 'danger' (סכנה/sakanah) in this context specifically refers to spiritual or metaphysical danger, not merely physical harm.

[2] This cryptic Talmudic saying suggests that if no immediate negative force (snake) is visible in these three domains, it's a sign that something is amiss. The underlying concept is that some spiritual resistance is normal and its complete absence may indicate hidden problems.

[i] This phrase from Proverbs 5:5 originally refers to the 'strange woman' or forbidden relations, but is reinterpreted here in kabbalistic terms to suggest that the feminine aspect (Malkhut) has an intrinsic connection to death when it turns toward external forces rather than divine influence.

[ii] The term 'katlanit' refers to a woman whose husbands tend to die. The author explains this halakhic concept through kabbalistic terms, suggesting it stems from the feminine realm's inherent connection to death.

דנחמא או הנאה דההוא בר נש
דהוי רע עין לאו איהו כדאי
למיכל ולאתהני מניה דאי כד
נחתו ישראל למצרים לא יטעמון
נחמא דמצראי לא אשתבקו
בגלותא ולא יעיקון לון מצראי
א״ל ר׳ יצחק והא גזרה אתגזר
א״ל כלא איהו כדקא יאות דהא
לא אתגזר דהא לא כתיב כי גר
יהיה זרעך בארץ מצרים אלא
בארץ לא להם ואפי׳ בארעא
אחרא. א״ר יצחק מאן דאיהו
בעל נפש דמכליה יתיר משאר
בני נשא או מאן דהוא אזיל
בתר מעוי אי אערא בהו רע עין
יכוס גרמיה ולא יכול מנחמא
דיליה דלית נחמא בישא בעלמא
בר מההוא רע עין. מה כתיב
כי לא יוכלון המצרים לאכול
את העברים לחם כי תועבה
היא למצרים הא לך רע עין.
ובערובין פ׳ כיצד משתתפין
אמרו שכל המצפה לשלחן חבירו
אפי׳ יהיה טוב עין העולם חושך
בעדו אולי ירצו כי לעולם לא
יקבל שפעו רק ע״י הנהגת החול
ימי חשך שהוא עולם מטטרו״ן
הנקרא בשר ודם וחייו אינם חיים
מעולם הכסא המחייה הכל רק
מעולם המות שהוא מעץ הדעת
טוב מטטרו״ן ורע ס״מ.[i] וישראל
בהיותם במצרים היו אוכלים
לחם העצבים בחנם. ובהיותם
תחת הנהגת משה רבינו עליו
השלום שהיה ממטיר להם לחם
מן השמים היו מתאוים למזון
גופניי הבא מכחות הנקראים
חנם. ואם תהיה כוונתו ללמוד
תורה אם ימות יחיה ולילה ביום
יאיר לו לעה״ב ועליו יאמר
אדם כי ימות באה״ל: ואפי׳ מי
שיש לו אב עצרן וקמצן בממונו

turns aside from the path and abandons the source of living waters to dig broken cisterns, for perhaps if he would lift his face to God and eat from the Merciful One's table,[1] the channel of his soul would be more prepared to receive with a generous eye.

And in the Zohar, Parshat Shemot, page 3, Rabbi Chiya began, "Do not eat the bread of one who has an evil eye, and do not desire his delicacies" (Proverbs 23:6). "Do not eat the bread of one who has an evil eye"—because the bread or benefit from a person who has an evil eye is not worthy to be eaten or enjoyed. For if when Israel descended to Egypt they had not tasted the bread of the Egyptians, they would not have remained in exile, and the Egyptians would not have oppressed them. Rabbi Yitzchak said to him: But a decree had been issued! He replied: Everything is as it should be, for it was not decreed specifically about Egypt, as it is not written, "Your seed shall be strangers in the land of Egypt," but rather "in a land that is not theirs" (Genesis 15:13), even in another land.

Rabbi Yitzchak said: One who is a person of appetite who eats more than other people, or one who follows his stomach—if he encounters an evil-eyed person, he should restrain himself and not eat of his bread, for there is no more evil bread in the world than that of one with an evil eye. What is written? "For the Egyptians could not eat bread with the Hebrews, for that is an abomination to the Egyptians" (Genesis 43:32). Behold, this is an evil eye.

And in Eruvin, chapter "How do they join [in an eruv]," they said that anyone who depends on his friend's table, even if [the friend] has a good eye, the world is dark for him. Perhaps they meant that he will never receive his divine flow except through the governance of the weekdays, days of darkness, which is the world of Metatron, who is called "flesh and blood," and his life is not life from the world of the Throne, which gives life to all, but rather from the world of death, which comes from the Tree of Knowledge—good is Metatron and evil is Samael.

And Israel, when they were in Egypt, were eating

[1] The original phrase 'מתכא דרחמנא' (mitka d'rachmana) is an Aramaic expression that literally means 'the table of the Merciful One,' referring to divine sustenance rather than human charity.

[i] This passage presents an unusual kabbalistic interpretation of the Tree of Knowledge, identifying its 'good' aspect with the angel Metatron and its 'evil' aspect with Samael. This formulation connects the mundane act of eating to cosmic spiritual forces.

יאכל פתו לבדו ולא ישמור ויצפה לארוחותיו הצרים ומה שאמרו במדבר רבה פ׳ ח׳ על פסוק בניך כשתילי זיתים סביב לשלחנך שלבניך יעמוד זכותך שמשלחנך יזכו בניך למעלות גדולות. אך שם במה הכתוב מדבר ביראא שמים דוקא שנותן בעין יפה דכתיב הנה כי כן יבורך גבר יראה׳ באברהם ושרה כי טוב עין הוא יבורך ופורתא מדידיה מסעיד סעיד והברכה שרויה במעים כאיוב שוותרן בממונו היה ולבן כל מי שהיה נוטל פרוטה ממנו מתברך. ואמר פתך אכלת לומר ודאי שכיון שבאת לעולם בא בכרך עמך כאשר נגזר בשעה שהובאה טיפתך לפני הפותח את ידו ומשביע לכל חי ברצון. וא״כ השפע שהיה לבא לך ממקום אחר אתה משעבד עצמך שיורק לך ע״י הרע עין הזה ולא יבוסם ולא יערב לך כי שולט בו צד הרע והורק לאשפה ועל כן אמר במקום אחר תחת שלש רגזה ארץ ואחד מהם ונבל כי ישבע לחם והנבל שהוא כלבי מצד בחינת הכלב שמזונותיו מועטים שלכן איחר הקב״ה מזונו במעיו ג׳ ימים להיותו דין חצוף המתהוה מזווג שור וחמור יחד ע״כ הנבל הזה כשמשפיע לאחרים נבלה ידבר והוא מלשון ידבר עמים תחתינו וע״כ רגזה ארץ החיים שממנה תצא לחם ומזון לכל חי שעל כן מברכים המוציא לחם מן הארץ ועל הארץ ועל המזון יען כי שפחה תירש גברתה כי נות בית תחלק שלל בעין יפה. וכתב הרמב״ן בפ׳ תולדות יצחק כי המתברכים מפי ה׳ לא יאונה להם עוני וחסרון וזה על דרך

the "bread of sorrow" for free. And when they were under the leadership of Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, who would rain down bread from heaven for them, they longed for physical nourishment that comes from forces called "free." And if his intention is to study Torah, even if he dies, he will live, and night will shine like day for him in the World to Come, and of him it will be said, "A man who dies in a tent" (Numbers 19:14). 140R 145R

Even one who has a miserly and stingy father regarding his wealth should eat his own bread alone and not wait and watch for his father's meager meals. And that which they said in Bamidbar Rabbah, chapter 8, on the verse "Your children like olive plants around your table" (Psalms 128:3)—that your merit will stand for your children, and from your table your children will merit great heights—that verse speaks specifically of one who fears Heaven and gives with a generous eye, as it is written, "Behold, thus shall the man who fears the Lord be blessed" (Psalms 128:4), like Abraham and Sarah,[1] for "he who is generous shall be blessed" (Proverbs 22:9), and a little from his own sustains [others], and blessing dwells in the intestines, like Job, who was generous with his wealth, and therefore anyone who took a coin from him was blessed. 150R 155R 160R 165R

And it says, "The morsel you have eaten" to tell you with certainty that when you came into the world, your loaf came with you, as was decreed at the time your drop [of semen] was brought before "He who opens His hand and satisfies the desire of every living thing" (Psalms 145:16). And thus, the divine flow that was to come to you from another place—you enslave yourself so that it comes to you through this evil-eyed person, and it will not be pleasant or agreeable to you, for the evil side controls it, and it is poured out to the refuse. Therefore, it says elsewhere, "For three things the earth trembles," and one of them is "a contemptible person who is sated with food" (Proverbs 30:21-22). 170R 175R

The contemptible one is like a dog in the aspect of the dog whose sustenance is meager, which is why the Holy One, blessed be He, delayed its food 180R

[1] The text assumes familiarity with Abraham and Sarah's legendary hospitality and generosity, traits that made them paradigms of 'good eye' in rabbinic literature.

שאמרו ברפואה.[i]

in its intestines for three days,[A] it being a brazen judgment that comes from the forbidden union of an ox and a donkey together. Therefore, when this contemptible one influences others, he speaks contemptible things,[B] which is from the language of "He will subdue the peoples under us" (Psalms 47:4). Therefore, the land of the living trembles, from which bread and nourishment come forth for all living things, which is why we bless "Who brings forth bread from the earth" and "for the land and for the sustenance." This is because "a maidservant inherits her mistress" (Proverbs 30:23), for "the women of the house divide the spoil" with a generous eye (Judges 5:30).

And Ramban wrote in the section on the generations of Isaac that those who are blessed by the mouth of the Lord will not suffer poverty and lack, and this is in the way they spoke of healing.[1]

ושפחה עינה רעה בשל אחרים וחוטפת וקומצת ואומרת שלי שלי ושלך שלי. וכמו שער בנפשה השפע שקבלה להריק לך שנעשתה מצע תחתיה ואכול ושתה תאמר לך ולבה בל עמך

And a maidservant has an evil eye regarding what belongs to others, snatching and hoarding and saying, "What is mine is mine, and what is yours is mine." Just as she has limited in her mind the abundance she received to pour out to you, having made herself a cushion beneath it, saying to you, "Eat and drink,"

[A] Or: "whose food is sparse, which is why the Holy One, blessed be He, made its digestion take three days" — This alternative more clearly conveys the traditional belief about dogs' digestive processes, which the author is using as a metaphor.

[B] Or: "he speaks vile things" — This alternative may better capture the strength of the Hebrew expression, which suggests not just contempt but actual vileness or disgrace in speech.

[1] This enigmatic ending refers to the rabbinic concept that spiritual principles apply in similar ways to both financial prosperity and physical healing—both depend on divine blessing and proper spiritual channels.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Shemot 3b — The passage cites this Zohar text to establish the spiritual danger of accepting food from someone with an evil eye, connecting it to Israel's experience in Egypt. This reference is essential for understanding the author's warning about the metaphysical consequences of receiving sustenance from negative sources. | Cf. Zohar, section called 'Sabba' (The Elder) — The text refers readers to the Sabba section of the Zohar for more details on the spiritual dangers of certain women. This section contains kabbalistic teachings about the feminine aspects of creation and their potential connections to negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Proverbs 23:6-8 — This biblical passage serves as the foundation for the author's warnings about accepting sustenance from people with negative spiritual qualities. The author interprets this verse as having mystical significance beyond its plain meaning. | Cf. Eruvin (Talmudic tractate) — The citation from Eruvin supports the author's position on spiritual independence, suggesting that one who depends on others' tables experiences spiritual darkness even if the provider has positive intentions. | Cf. Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah, chapter 8 — This reference is used to qualify when parental merit transfers to children—specifically when the parent gives generously and fears Heaven. The author uses this to contrast with the earlier warnings about miserly providers. | Cf. Genesis 15:13 — This reference is used in the Zohar citation to make a technical point about the nature of the Egyptian exile decree, suggesting that the specific location was not predetermined but resulted from Israel's actions in eating Egyptian bread.

כמו שאמרו על שלשים וחמשה
שרים שמצד שמאל[i] שמקמצין
מהשפע הניתן להם ונותנים
195 אותו בעין רעה וא״כ למה תשגה
בני בזרה ותחבק חק נכריה כי
שחת דברך הנעימים הנהגותך
שאם היו באים לך שלא על
יד צר עין זה שמחמת פחיתות
200 נפשך וקוצר אמונתך בה׳ עיניך
תלויות לו מוכנים היו לבא לך
מדרכי הנועם העליון ברוב טוב
ושפע ואתה שחת אותם ולהיות
כי משפיל צמר נשמתו לקבל
205 מהנהגת מטטרו״ן ימי החול
ששם כחות החנם גם יחודיו
ומעשיו הטובים לא יעוררו
אפי׳ בשבתות וימים טובים רק
עד מקום קבלת נשמתו וזהו
210 ושחת דבריך הנעימים שלא
יגיעו עד הנועם העליון שהיא
בינה דמקננא בכורסייא יען כי
בבחינת עבד אתה למטטרו״ן
ולהיות בה׳ מבטחך הודעתיך
215 היום אני. ואמרו במדרש כל
ימי עני באמונה הם רעים דוגמת
הנחש כי ירא שיחסר לו עפר
למאכלו וטוב לב ומאמין בקונו
כי יזמין לו פרנסתו משתה
220 תמיד כי גם ה׳ יתן אליו הטוב
מרחובות הנהר כרוחב לבו
באמונתו. ושר העולם אמר לא
ראיתי צדיק נעזב וזרעו מבקש
לחם ואי צורבא דרבנן מעני
225 אהדורא אפתחא לא מהדר. ועל

but her heart is not with you. This is like what they said about the thirty-five ministers from the left side who withhold from the abundance given to them and distribute it with an evil eye. So why, my son, do you 210R
go astray with a strange woman and embrace the bosom of a foreigner? For you have corrupted your pleasant words and your conduct. If they had come to you not through this grudging person—because of your diminished spirit and your lack of faith in God, 215R
your eyes being dependent on him—they would have been prepared to come to you through the ways of supreme pleasantness with abundant goodness and prosperity. But you have corrupted them.

Because one who lowers the wool of his soul[A] to 220R
receive from the governance of Metatron during the weekdays, where the forces of gratuitous gifts[B] reside, even his unifications and good deeds will not awaken, even on Sabbaths and festivals, beyond the place of his soul's reception. This is the meaning 225R
of "you have corrupted your pleasant words"—that they will not reach the supreme pleasantness, which is Binah nesting in the Throne,[C] since you are in the aspect of a servant to Metatron. But if your trust is in the Lord, I am informing you today. 230R

They said in the Midrash: "All the days of the poor who has faith are evil," like the serpent who fears he will lack earth for his food. But one who is good of heart and has faith in his Creator, who will provide his sustenance, will always feast, for God 235R
will also give him goodness from the expanses of the river, according to the breadth of his heart in his faith. And the Prince of the World said: "I have not seen a righteous person abandoned, nor his offspring seeking bread." And if a Torah scholar becomes poor, 240R

[A] Or: "one who debases the essence of his soul" — The phrase 'צמר נשמתו' (wool of his soul) is likely a metaphorical expression. While 'wool' (צמר) is the literal translation, it might be referring to the essence or substance of the soul. The alternate translation captures the metaphorical meaning better, though the original is more literal.

[B] Or: "forces of mundane provision" — The term 'כחות החנם' is difficult to translate precisely. While 'חנם' often means 'free' or 'gratuitous,' in this context it might refer to mundane or worldly provisions, contrasted with divine abundance. The alternate translation captures this contextual meaning.

[C] Or: "Binah (Understanding) that nests in the Divine Throne" — The alternate translation adds explanatory information that 'Binah' refers to 'Understanding,' which is helpful for readers unfamiliar with Kabbalistic terminology. Both translations are accurate, but the alternate provides more context.

[i] In Kabbalistic literature, especially the Zohar, the 'left side' represents the side of judgment, restriction, and withholding, while the 'right side' represents mercy and giving. These thirty-five ministers are spiritual forces that distribute divine influence with restriction rather than abundance.

הרוב ממרחק תביא לחמה כי בצל החכמה בצל הכסף. ואמרו רבנן כי צרי עין אפי׳ עופות השמים מכירים אותם שהמלאכים
230 אשר בעולם העשיה ששם ה׳ משטרם בארץ הנקרא עוף המעופפים על הארץ משפיעים לו גם הם בעין רעה שהכל כפי המקבל וכלי ריקן מברכה אינו
235 מחזיק.[i] ואין טוב לכל אדם רק לצפות מחיתו ומחית בניו מאת אבינו מן השמים שלכן אמרו על ר׳ פנחס בן יאיר מיום שעמד על דעתו לא נהנה מסעודת
240 אביו.[ii] וכ״ש אם הבן בלבו יבין ובאזניו ישמע דהאי גברא לא בעי בר שטוב לו לשית לבו ופני צאנו הבנים בניו והבנות בנותיו לעדרים עליונים אשר בהם די
245 חלב עז ותעצומות ללחם ביתו וחיים לנערותיו ואז לא ייראו לביתו משלג וממרחק יביא לחמו והאשת חיל תתן טרף לביתו וחוק לנערותיו ותאמץ זרועותיו
250 ועז והדר יהיה לבושו ותורת חסד על לשונו להודות תמיד לנותן לחם לכל בשר ועיניו יצפו לו כי לעולם חסדו בברכת אשר לא עשאני עבד[iii] ובזה יקומו
255 בניו ויאשרוהו מלכות בנותיו ופילגשיו ויהללוהו כי איש בזה ירא ה׳ הוא יתהלל ומאוצר של חסד יוסיפו לו על פרי ידיו ויהללוהו בשערים מעשיו.
260 וכל הפותח פתחו לחבירו חייב בכבודו יותר מאביו ואמו כדאמרי׳ בשמות רבה פ״ד. ולא תהא עדות גדולה מראיה ואין חכם כבעל הנסיון:[iv]

he does not go back to the doorway begging. Generally, "from afar she brings her bread," for "in the shadow of wisdom is the shadow of money."

The Rabbis said that even the birds of heaven recognize those who are grudging, for the angels who 245R
are in the World of Asiyah, where God established their dominion on earth—called "birds flying over the earth"—they too bestow upon such a person with an evil eye, for everything is according to the receiver, and an empty vessel cannot contain bless- 250R
ing. It is not good for any person except to expect his livelihood and the livelihood of his children from our Father in Heaven. Therefore, they said of Rabbi Pinchas ben Yair that from the day he gained understanding, he did not benefit from his father's meal. 255R

All the more so if the son understands in his heart and hears with his ears that this man does not desire a son, it is good for him to set his heart and direct his flock—his sons and his daughters—to the celestial flocks in which there is sufficient potent milk and 260R
strength for the bread of his household and life for his maidens. Then "he will not fear for his household from snow," and "from afar he will bring his bread." The woman of valor will "provide food for her household and a portion for her maidens," she 265R
will strengthen his arms, and "strength and dignity will be his clothing." The Torah of kindness will be on his tongue to always thank the One who gives bread to all flesh, and his eyes will look to Him, "for His kindness is eternal," like the blessing "who has 270R
not made me a slave." In this way, "his children will rise up and call him blessed," his daughters will be queens, and his concubines will praise him, for such a man who fears the Lord shall be praised. From the treasury of kindness, they will increase the fruit 275R
of his hands, and "his deeds will praise him in the gates."

Anyone who opens his door to his friend is obligated to honor him more than his father and mother,

[i] This is based on a Talmudic teaching that empty vessels can hold blessing, while full ones cannot. Here it's used ironically—those who are spiritually 'empty' through their stinginess cannot receive divine blessing.

[ii] Rabbi Pinchas ben Yair was known for his extreme piety and self-sufficiency. This story about him refusing to eat at his father's table from the time he gained maturity illustrates the ideal of independence from human providers and complete reliance on God.

[iii] This references one of the morning blessings in Jewish liturgy, 'Blessed are You...who has not made me a slave.' The author connects this blessing to the concept of being free from dependence on human masters, suggesting that true freedom comes from reliance on God alone.

[iv] Cf. Zohar — The text is drawing on Kabbalistic cosmology from the Zohar to explain how spiri-

as they said in Exodus Rabbah, chapter 84. And there is no greater testimony than eyewitness, and no one is wiser than one who has experience. 280R

פרק י״ג

Chapter 13

יש הרבה דברים שבנים של אדם מתים עליהם ות״ח היודע זה ואינו נזהר עתיד ליתן את הדין. ואין לקלל בניו ובנותיו כי ברית כרותה לשפתים וכמו שברית כרותה לשפתי ברכת הורים להיות עודפת על ברכת האחרים להיות נפש הבנים עלולים תחתם כן ח״ו קללתם אפי׳ על חנם היא באה כמו שאמרו על קללת חכם.[i] וגם על זה ירחיק הבן מאביו ומאמו אם אי אפשר לו בענין אחר פן יבולע לו ולמשפחתו. ומי שאין מתקיימין לו בנים יכול אחר לפדותו וליתן כופר נפשו

There are many things that cause a person's children to die, and a Torah scholar who knows this and is not careful will have to give an account in the future.[A] One should not curse one's sons and daughters, for there is a covenant made with the lips.[B] Just as there is a covenant made with parental blessings to be more effective than the blessings of others—since children's souls are susceptible to their parents' influence[1]—so too, God forbid, their curses, even if uttered without justification, will take effect, as they say regarding a sage's curse. For this reason, a son should distance himself from his father and mother if he cannot manage the situation differently, lest harm befall him and his family. One whose children do not survive may have another person redeem him and offer a ransom for his soul, and he should be called the 5R 10R 15R

[A] Or: "and a Torah scholar who knows this but fails to take precautions will ultimately be held accountable" — This alternative provides a slightly clearer rendering of the concept of future divine judgment while maintaining the serious tone of the warning.

[B] Or: "words have binding power" — This is a more idiomatic English expression of the rabbinic concept that spoken words have inherent power to actualize what they express, though it loses the specific covenant metaphor.

[1] The original phrase 'להיות נפש הבנים עלולים תחתם' literally means 'the souls of children are liable/susceptible under them'—expressing the kabbalistic concept that children's souls are spiritually connected to and influenced by their parents.

tual forces distribute divine abundance. The 'left side' in Kabbalah generally represents the side of judgment and restriction, contrasted with the 'right side' of mercy and giving. This reference helps establish the author's argument that those who are stingy mirror negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Proverbs 31 — The author weaves together verses from Proverbs 31 to describe the ideal of self-sufficiency through divine providence. By invoking the biblical archetype of the woman of valor, the text suggests that proper faith in God leads to the same kind of industriousness, provision, and dignity described in Proverbs 31. | Cf. Psalm 136 — By incorporating this liturgical refrain from Psalm 136, the author emphasizes that gratitude to God for sustenance should be constant and ritualized, similar to the way this refrain is used in Jewish prayer. It reinforces the theme that trusting in divine providence should be accompanied by regular thanksgiving. | Cf. Mishlei (Proverbs) 7:5-27 — The author uses this biblical imagery metaphorically—the 'strange woman' represents dependence on human generosity rather than divine providence. Just as Proverbs warns against literal sexual impropriety, this text warns against the spiritual impropriety of placing one's trust in stingy human providers rather than in God. | Cf. Kabbalistic cosmology — The author uses Kabbalistic concepts to explain how one's spiritual focus affects material provision. By mentioning that even good deeds won't reach beyond 'the place of his soul's reception' if one is focused on Metatron (associated with worldly affairs) rather than higher divine attributes, the text establishes a cosmological framework for understanding the spiritual consequences of improper dependency.

[i] This refers to the Talmudic teaching that a sage's curse, even if conditional or unintentional, can have profound effects (see Makkot 11a, Sanhedrin 90b).

ויקרא בנו של אחר[i] אולי ירחמו
עליו מן השמים שיכול להיות
שנגזר מיתת ערירי על האב
ומי יודע אם בכופר זה ינצל
בנו. מנהגנו שלא לחלוץ האבל
מנעליו עד שיגיע לביתו גם שכפי
הדין כשנסתם הגולל חל עליו
האבלות. וכתב בספר החסידים
כי אדם אחד היה נוהג בעצמו
כשהיה אדם אבל היה הוא חוזר
לביתו עמו בלא מנעלים כדי
להצטער עם האבל. ויום שמת
בו אירע בתשעה באב[ii] ונתקבצו
כל הקהלות לאותה העיר והלכו
הכל לקבורתו יחפים ובזה הוכר
שהיה חסד זה רצוי לפניו ית׳.
ואמרו שאע״פ שהצדיקים יודעין
שחלקן טוב לעה״ב מצטערים מן
המיתה ומאימת מ״ה כדאמר רב
סעוריה לאחוהי רבא כד היה
מתנמנם פירש גוסס לימא מר
למ״ה דלא לצערן[iii] ואמרו שם
מאן ספין ומאן חשוב קמיה כי לא
ישא פני כל ואפי׳ כלבים בוכים
מאימתו וזהו שנאמר במצרים
הגם שהיתה מלאה מחבלים
ולכל בני ישראל לא יחרץ כלב
לשונו והכלב חוזר לאחריו
כשרואה מ״ה כי אין השדים
רשאים לעבור אלא בדרך הנגזר
להם כנזכר למעלה. ואם ידוחה
הכלב לפניו וימות באשר יבא
לקמן יהיה כפרה לאדם ההוא
וסמך קצת גם אוחבה הרגתי

son of the other person; perhaps Heaven will have mercy on him, as it may be that childless death was decreed upon the father,[1] and who knows if through this ransom his son will be saved. 20R

Our custom is not to remove mourners' shoes until they reach home, even though according to the law, mourning begins when the grave is sealed. It is written in Sefer Hasidim that a certain man, when someone was in mourning, would accompany him 25R
home barefoot to share in the mourner's distress. On the day he died, which happened to be the Ninth of Av, all the communities gathered in that city and everyone went to his burial barefoot, and by this it was recognized that this act of kindness was pleasing 30R
before the Blessed One.

They say that even though the righteous know that their portion in the World to Come is good, they still fear death and dread the Angel of Death. As Rav Se'oriah said to his brother Rava when he was 35R
dozing off (meaning in a coma),[2] "Let the master tell the Angel of Death not to torment us." And they said there, "Who is important enough before him? For he shows no favoritism." Even dogs cry out of fear of him, as it says regarding Egypt—though it was full 40R
of destructive forces—"but against all the children of Israel, no dog shall sharpen its tongue." A dog turns back when it sees the Angel of Death, for demons are not permitted to cross except by the path decreed for them, as mentioned above. And if a dog is pushed 45R
before him and dies, as will be explained later, it will be an atonement for that person. There is some support for this in the verse, "I killed Ochah and revived her."

The righteous also fear the Beating of the 50R

[1] The Hebrew term 'ערירי' (ariri) specifically refers to the biblical concept of dying without children to carry on one's lineage, considered a severe divine punishment in ancient Near Eastern cultures.
[2] I've added an explanatory note that 'מתנמנם' (dozing off) in this context refers to a dying person in a coma-like state, not ordinary sleep, based on the context of speaking to the Angel of Death.

[i] This practice of symbolic adoption and redemption was a folk remedy for families who had lost multiple children, designed to confuse or appease the destructive forces believed to be targeting the family.
[ii] The Ninth of Av is the major Jewish fast day commemorating the destruction of both Temples and other tragedies. That this pious man died on this day and that people naturally came barefoot (as is customary on this fast) is interpreted as divine approval of his practice.
[iii] מ״ה is an abbreviation for מלאך המות (Angel of Death). This story shows that even great sages feared the pain of death and sought to negotiate with the Angel of Death through intermediaries.

ואותה החייתי.[i] והצדיקים מתייראים גם מחיבוט הקבר ואפי׳ יונקי שדים אין נצולין ממנו[ii] כי זוהמת הנחש לנערה ולהוציא כלי למעשהו צריך חביטה. (ולכן כתיב ונפש אויבך יקלענה בתוך כף הקלע ולזה תועיל גרירת העצמות כאשר כתבנו. ומי שפוגם אות ברית קדש ח״ו נדון בחבוט הקבר כמ״ש בתקונים מאן דלא נטיר ברית מילה איתדן בחיבוט הקבר בההוא עפר ואלה הם הגופא דלהון אינון לון קבר ודוחקין להון בכל יומא ומלאכא דלהון. ובעפר של המילה מצילו מחבוט הקבר ובדם מילה מציל אותו משחיטת מ״ה אשרי המרגיל עצמו במילת הבנים לש״ש ואמר כי ערלת ממזר בעפר היא תקון לנחש[iii]). וכן כח הדין כדאמרי׳ בערבה חביט חביט ולא בריך וכתוב בחקור דין שבגרעיני הערבה ימצא בתוכם כדמות נחש בלא ראש[iv] ובזה אותו הגוף מתוקן לחיות בטל אורות של התחיה בגבול חדש

Grave,[A] and even nursing infants are not spared from it, for the serpent's defilement must be shaken off, and to prepare a vessel for its purpose requires beating. (Therefore it is written, "The soul of your enemy will be slung in the hollow of a sling," and for this, dragging the bones is beneficial, as we have written. And one who damages the sign of the holy covenant, God forbid, is judged with the Beating of the Grave, as written in Tikkunim: "He who does not guard the covenant of circumcision is judged with the Beating of the Grave in that dust, and these are the ones whose bodies become their graves and oppress them every day, along with their angel. The dust of circumcision saves one from the Beating of the Grave,[1] and the blood of circumcision saves one from slaughter by the Angel of Death. Fortunate is one who accustoms himself to circumcising boys for the sake of Heaven. And it was said that the foreskin of a bastard buried in dust is a remedy for the serpent.") 55R 60R 65R 70R

So too is the power of judgment, as they say regarding the willow: "Beat, beat, but do not bless."[2] And it is written in Chakur Din that within willow seeds one finds something resembling a headless snake, and through this, the body is prepared to live in the dew-light of resurrection in a new realm, like pure wool.[3] Among angels too 75R

[A] Or: "Chibut HaKever (the Torment of the Grave)" — Using the original Hebrew term with an English explanation might be preferable for this mystical concept that doesn't have a standard English equivalent and is a specific technical term in Jewish eschatology.

[1] The text refers to the Jewish practice of burying the foreskin after circumcision, suggesting it has protective spiritual power. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that ritual objects retain spiritual energy after their use.

[2] This refers to the ritual of beating willow branches (aravah) during the Hoshana Rabbah prayers, where traditionally the branches are beaten without a blessing, unlike other ritual objects used during Sukkot.

[3] The image of 'עמר נקי' (pure wool) alludes to Daniel 7:9 describing the Ancient of Days whose 'raiment was white as snow, and the hair of his head like pure wool,' symbolizing divine purity.

[i] The reference is unclear but appears to be from a rabbinic source describing how God kills and brings life, possibly a homiletical interpretation of Deuteronomy 32:39, "I kill and I make alive."

[ii] This statement, that even nursing infants must undergo the "Beating of the Grave," addresses the theological problem of why innocent children suffer. The mystical answer provided is that all souls, even those of infants, carry the primordial impurity from the serpent in Eden that must be purified.

[iii] The text presents a curious folk remedy suggesting that burying the foreskin of a mamzer (child born of a forbidden relationship) in dust can somehow remedy or neutralize the power of the primordial serpent. This likely reflects folk practices that existed alongside more formal kabbalistic teachings.

[iv] This observation about willow seeds resembling headless snakes represents the kabbalistic principle of finding spiritual correspondences in the natural world, suggesting that the physical properties of objects reflect their spiritual functions.

כעמר נקי. וג״כ במלאכים יש ביניהם צער והם שמחים
80 כשהנפש שוה להם. ומלאכי חבלה דומים לרשעים כדאמרי׳ הרשעים הן הן המזיקים מלבד כי באשתם יצתו כי הם מביאים עצים לגיהנם ירצה שחטאיהם
85 הם סבה להרבות מלאכי חבלה וקודחי אש לגיהנם וע״י חמום עבירותיהם העמיק הרחיב מדורתם אש ועצים הרבה. ואין מפוח הנופח יותר בגי הנום כמי
90 שכועס שכל מיני גיהנם שולטים בו ומטמא גופו ונפשו כי בזה שמחים בצאתם ששים בבואם במדורות גיהנם כל מלאכי חבלה. ועל הכועס נאמר טורף
95 נפשו באפו[i] כי האדם עושה נפשו טריפה ומשליכה ממנו בכעסו וגם שעושה תקונים ומצות רבות נאבדים ממנו לגמרי כי הולכת אותה הנפש ובאה אחרת במקומה
100 וצריך לחזור ולתקן כמתחלה. והמקובל האר״י זצוק״ל היה נזהר ומזהיר לתלמידיו על זה מאד ואפי׳ יהיה הכעס על דבר מצוה היה מונע לתלמידיו
105 ממנו. ואמרו כי שם אהי״ה במלואו עולה קנ״א כמנין כעס והכוללל[ii] ושם זה יכוין בשעת הטבילה לטהר פגם הכעס שכן עולה במנין מקו״ה. ומצאתי
110 כי טוב לבעל תשובה לטבול י״ד טבילות למתוק י״ד עתים

there is distress, and they rejoice when a soul equals them.

Angels of destruction resemble the wicked, as they say, "The wicked are themselves the destructive forces," besides the fact that "with their fire they ignite"—meaning their sins cause an increase in angels of destruction and those who kindle fire in Gehenna, and through the heat of their transgressions, they deepen and widen their pyre with much fire and wood. 80R 85R

There is no bellows that blows more in Gehenna than one who becomes angry,[A] for all types of Gehenna rule over him and defile his body and soul. All angels of destruction rejoice at his departure and are glad at his entry into the chambers of Gehenna. About the angry person it is said, "He tears his soul in his anger,"[1] for a person makes his soul damaged and casts it away in his anger. Even if he performs many rectifications and commandments, they are completely lost to him because that soul departs and another comes in its place, and he must start the rectification process anew. The kabbalist, the ARI of blessed memory, was very careful about this and strongly warned his disciples, and even if the anger was about a matter of a commandment, he would prevent his disciples from it. 90R 95R 100R

They said that the divine name Ehyeh in its full spelling equals 151, the same numerical value as "anger" plus one, and one should focus on this name during immersion to purify the blemish of anger, as it equals the numerical value of "mikveh." I found that it is good for a penitent to immerse fourteen times to sweeten the fourteen times[2] [of judgment], and he should further intend in the first immersion to 105R 110R

[A] Or: "No bellows fans the flames of Gehenna more than a person's anger" — This alternative captures the metaphorical meaning more vividly while maintaining the comparison between anger and a bellows inflaming Gehenna.

[1] The original phrase 'טורף נפשו באפו' is from Job 18:4, though with a kabbalistic interpretation that anger literally damages and displaces one's soul.

[2] The original 'למתוק י״ד עתים' refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening' harsh judgments, transforming them from severity to mercy. The fourteen times likely refers to the fourteen aspects of divine judgment in kabbalistic thought.

[i] A play on Job 18:4, which is interpreted here to mean that anger literally tears one's soul and renders it 'treif' (non-kosher/damaged), requiring its replacement with a new soul.

[ii] The divine name Ehyeh (אהיה) in its 'full' spelling (אלף הי יוד הי) has the numerical value 151, which equals the numerical value of the Hebrew word for anger (כעס = 150) plus 1 (the kollel, or inclusive number). This gematria (numerical equivalence) creates a mystical connection between the divine name and the purification from anger.

ועוד יכוין בטבילה ראשונה להסיר הזוהמא וביי״ג להמשיך עליו האורת תלת עשר מכילן
115 דרחמי על כן טוב לומר פסוקי מי אל כמוך נושא עון ועובר על פשע. ישוב ירחמנו יכבוש עונותינו. תתן אמת ליעקב חסד לאברהם. ויוסיף מדה אי בכל
120 טבילה. עוד בשהאדם בועס אסור להסתכל בו כי עם ראיית עינים מלאך רע עומד וממהר לנקום על צערו ועוד קשה לשכחה. ועיין פי תצוה דף קמ״ב
125 גודל פגם הבועס וכן להסתכל בפני האשה בשעה שדמיה מצויים בה ואמרו שיתראה במבט עיניה אז כדמות נחש וכבר אמרנו בגמרא מסכנת העובר באמצע
130 בי נשים טמאות[i] ואמרו דיפתח באל ויסיים באל. אל מוציאם ממצרים וגו׳ כי לא נחש ביעקב וגו׳ או יפתח בלא ויסיים בלא וה׳ רגלי חסידיו ישמור:[ii]

remove impurity, and in the thirteenth to draw upon himself the illumination of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy.[A] Therefore, it is good to recite verses like "Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over transgression," "He will again have compassion upon us, He will subdue our iniquities," "Give truth to Jacob, kindness to Abraham," and add one attribute in each immersion. 115R

Furthermore, when someone is angry, it is forbidden to look at them, for with the sight of the eyes, an evil angel stands ready to take revenge for his distress, and it also causes forgetfulness. See Parashat Tetzaveh, page 142, on the great blemish of one who becomes angry, and likewise looking at a woman when her blood flows, for they say that in her gaze at such times there appears the likeness of a serpent. We have already mentioned in the Talmud the danger to one who passes between two ritually impure women, and they say one should begin with "El" and end with "El" [divine name]:[1] "El [God] who brings them out of Egypt, etc." "For there is no enchantment in Jacob, etc." Or begin with "Lo" and end with "Lo" [negation]: "And the LORD will guard the feet of His faithful ones."" 120R 125R 130R 135R

[A] Or: "to channel upon himself the divine light of the Thirteen Attributes of Compassion" — This alternative uses terminology that may be more familiar to readers of mystical texts in English, with 'channel' capturing the kabbalistic concept of drawing down divine energy and 'compassion' being another common translation for 'rachamim'.

[1] The text is recommending specific biblical verses that begin and end with the divine name 'El' as protective formulas against the danger mentioned. This reflects the Jewish mystical practice of using divine names for protection.

[i] The text refers to a Talmudic warning (Pesachim 111a) about the danger to one who passes between two menstruating women, reflecting beliefs about ritual impurity having potentially harmful physical effects.

[ii] Cf. Sefer Hasidim — The text cites Sefer Hasidim as a source for the pious practice of walking barefoot with mourners, showing how this mystical work draws on earlier Jewish ethical traditions to support its arguments about proper behavior toward the dead and mourners. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The reference to 'Tikkunim' regarding punishment for one who damages the covenant of circumcision shows how Ma'avar Yabok integrates Zoharic kabbalistic teachings into its framework of understanding posthumous judgment and purification. | Cf. Teachings of the ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria) — The citation of the ARI's teachings about anger shows how Ma'avar Yabok incorporates Lurianic Kabbalah, particularly regarding the damage anger causes to the soul and the importance of avoiding it even in seemingly justified circumstances. | Cf. Talmudic references to the Angel of Death — The anecdote about Rav Se'oriah speaking to his brother Rava about the Angel of Death draws on Talmudic material to support the text's claims about how even the righteous fear death and the universality of the Angel of Death's power. | Cf. Exodus 11:7 — The reference to dogs not sharpening their tongues against the Israelites in Egypt is from Exodus 11:7, used here to develop the mystical understanding that animals, particularly dogs, can sense the Angel of Death and naturally fear it.

פרק י״ד

Chapter 14

בחרתי להציע לפני תלמידי תלמידיהון דרבנן כוונת בקור חולים מלבד מ״ש בחלק א׳ בזה. וטעם המיתה. וצדוק הדין. וההספד. והלוית המת. וקבורתו. וההבראה. ושאר כמה דברים הנוהגים בישראל בתנחומי אבלים מדברי חכמים אשר הם כמסמרות נטועים כי מלאכת שמים היא ולא יהיה מדרש זה בלא חדוש על דברי חכמים מלמדי לאדם דעת.

I have chosen to present before students of the disciples of our rabbis the deeper meaning of visiting the sick, beyond what I have already written in Part One. And the reason for death. And the justification of divine judgment. And the eulogy. And the funeral procession. And burial. And the meal of consolation. And several other practices observed in Israel in comforting mourners, from the words of our Sages, which are like planted nails, for this is the work of Heaven. This exposition will not be without innovation regarding the words of the Sages who teach humanity knowledge.

רמז ביקור חולים הוא כי האדם המבקר החולה מיקל חליו כנראה מתלמידו של ר״ע ואם הוא בן גילו כפרש״י שנולד במזלו צערו אשר יצטער עליו[i] יהיה לחולה הצלה פורתא בנכוי אחד מששים בחליו שלפחות ישפוך שיחו בכאבו בתפלתו עליו אחר שביקר אותו. ונקט לשון בקור ולא לשון ראיה והליכה והקבלה להורות לאדם דעת שילמד לחולה שיפשפש ויבקר מעשיו[ii] כי בסור הסבה יסור המסובב. ובזה יפה כחו להפוך אחד מששים כלליות שהם מגבורה ולמטה עד מלכות[iii] שיהא מלאך מליץ עליו ואפי׳ א׳ מאלף באותו מלאך לפעמים די וכ״ש אחד מששים וגם אם נאמר ששים הוא מורגל בפי רבנן שתין רהוטי וכו׳ שתין תכלי וכו׳ וכדומה הרבה. ברם

The hint about visiting the sick is that the person who visits the ill lightens their suffering, as we see from the student of Rabbi Akiva. And if the visitor is a "son of his age" (born under the same astrological sign), as Rashi explains, the distress that he feels on behalf of the sick person provides some small salvation, reducing one-sixtieth of the illness—at the very least because he pours out his heart in painful prayer after visiting.

The text uses the term "bikur" (examination) rather than terms for seeing, going, or receiving, to teach that one should instruct the sick person to examine and inspect their deeds,[1] for when the cause is removed, the effect will be removed. Through this, the visitor has the power to transform one-sixtieth of the totality [of judgment], which extends from Gevurah down to Malkhut,[2] so that an angel will advocate for the sick person. Sometimes even one part in a thousand of that angel's intervention is sufficient, and certainly one part in sixty. Even if we say that "sixty" is simply a common expression among the rabbis—"sixty runners," "sixty vessels,"

[1] The original text makes a wordplay on the Hebrew term 'bikur' (visiting), connecting it to 'examination.' I've attempted to preserve this conceptual connection though the wordplay is lost in English.

[2] This passage employs kabbalistic terminology to describe how visiting the sick affects the divine attributes. Gevurah represents divine judgment, while Malkhut represents the divine presence in the physical world. The visitation is seen as transforming the judgment into mercy.

[i] The concept of 'ben gilo' (one born under the same astrological sign) refers to the belief that people born under the same constellation share a spiritual connection. The text suggests this connection makes visitation more effective in healing.

[ii] The term 'bikur' (visiting) is connected to the same Hebrew root as 'examination.' The author is making a linguistic connection to suggest that proper visitation of the sick should include encouraging self-examination of deeds.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that visiting the sick transforms a portion of the divine judgment (extending from Gevurah to Malkhut in the sefirotic system) into mercy.

מדברי הגמרא נראה דהכא ששים דוקא דאמר וליעיילו ששים וכו׳. וכבר דברנו מזה למעלה בחלק ראשון פרק ב׳. ומדת החסד אינה נכנסת במנין הזה[i] כי על ידה מושפעת הרפואה מארי״ך ולעולם הוא לו למגן. ואחר הביקור חוזר להיות רופא חולים דהיינו מרכבה לת״ת מצד הכתר ששם ארוכה[ii] ורמז ביקור חולים לתקון גבוה [iii]

and many similar phrases—nevertheless, from the Talmud it appears that here "sixty" is precise, as it states "and let sixty enter..." We have already discussed this above in Part One, Chapter 2.

The attribute of Chesed (Loving-kindness) is not included in this calculation because through it healing flows from Arich Anpin, and it always serves as a shield.[1] After the visitation, one becomes a "healer of the sick," meaning a vehicle for Tiferet from the perspective of Keter,[2] where healing resides. Thus, visiting the sick alludes to supernal rectification.

כי לזה תהיה כוונת עובד האמתי כאשר למדונו רבותינו בכל חותמי הברכות שאמרו שצריך להיות הפתיחה מעין החתימה וכן סמוך לחתימה יהיה מעין הברכה. כלל גדול למדונו בזה כי אחר שסדרנו סדר הברכה אם היא ברכת שבח והודאה או ברכות המצות או שאלת צרכים או ברכות הנהנין הכל יהיה לתכלית שיבורך שמו הגדול בהשפעת שפע הברכה כאשה כי יתרבה החלב ע״י

For this should be the intention of the true worshiper, as our Rabbis taught us regarding all conclusions of blessings, saying that the opening must reflect the conclusion, and similarly, near the conclusion should reflect the essence of the blessing. They taught us a great principle in this:[3] after we have arranged the order of the blessing—whether it is a blessing of praise and thanksgiving, blessings over commandments, requests for needs, or blessings over enjoyments—everything should be for the purpose that His great name be blessed through the flow of blessing, like a woman whose milk increases through the infant nursing from the mother's breasts. This,

[1] Arich Anpin ('Long Face') is a complex kabbalistic concept referring to a high divine configuration associated with mercy. The author suggests that the attribute of Chesed connects directly to this higher source of healing.

[2] This describes the mystical transformation of the visitor. By visiting properly, they become a conduit (merkavah/vehicle) for divine healing energy flowing from Keter (the highest divine attribute) through Tiferet (the central balancing attribute).

[3] The author is establishing a kabbalistic principle that proper prayer and blessing creates a reciprocal relationship between human action and divine response, much like the relationship between nursing and milk production.

[i] The author explains that Chesed (Loving-kindness) is not included in the calculation of sixty because it operates on a different principle—it functions as a shield rather than needing to be transformed from judgment.

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic mechanism of healing: the visitor becomes a vehicle (merkavah) for Tiferet (central divine attribute) which connects to Keter (the highest attribute) where the source of healing resides.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part One, Chapter 2 — The author refers to a previous discussion of the same topic in Part One of Ma'avar Yabok, indicating that this is an expansion of his earlier treatment of visiting the sick. This shows the book's organizational structure and the author's systematic approach to these topics. | Cf. Talmudic discussion of visiting the sick — The author mentions the Talmudic discussion about 'let sixty enter' which appears to be a reference to a specific Talmudic passage about visiting the sick. The number sixty is being emphasized as having particular significance beyond just being a conventional number. | Cf. Rashi's commentary on 'ben gilo' (son of his age/astrological sign) — The author cites Rashi's interpretation of 'ben gilo' as referring to someone born under the same astrological sign, which creates a special connection that makes visiting the sick more effective when done by such a person.

התינוק היונק משדי האם[i] וזוהי
לדעתי כוונה נאותה בכל חתימת
ופתיחת ברכות מלבד כוונת
שם י״ב[ii] שצריך לכוין בחתימה
והוא מוקבל מאד למה שכתבנו
למעלה כוונת העונה ברוך הוא
וברוך שמו פוק עיין על זה הדרך
יכוין בבקרו החולה שבג״ח הזה
פוקד ומבקר חולים שהם תפארת
ומלכות שהם חולים באומרו
כי חולת אהבה אני[iii] והוא
מחזקם ומפקדם בבקרו אותם
דהיינו אומרו סמכוני באשישות
רפדוני בתפוחים. והם בגדולה
וגבורה תרין אשישות ובנ״ה תרין
תפוחים כמו שפי׳ בתקונים.
וכן האדם בהיותו עוסק במצוה
זו גורם להשפיע משם החוזק
והכח כמו שהוא מחזיק החולה
בבקור ומיקל מעליו כח הרעה
חולה בנזכר. ורפואת חולים
הוא כי בהיות האדם כבד
בחליו מודה באותו חולי היות
כח החצוני שולט עליו הנאמר
באיוב הנו בידך וכל חולי
שבעולם הוא רוח הטומאה
המתלבש בדין על האדם.[iv] ובזה
יורד הפגם מלמעלה ומתקדש
משכן הקדש מהחשך אשר החשיך
שם במקום אחיזת נשמתו וזהו
כוונת ואתה צדיק על כל הבא
עלינו: ולהיות החולי כח רע
הניתן עליו להחליאו זהו שאמרה
נאמנים לשולחיהם שאותו הדין

in my opinion, is an appropriate intention for all
conclusions and openings of blessings, besides the
intention of the twelve-letter Name that one must
focus on during the conclusion, which corresponds
well to what we wrote above regarding the intention
of one who responds "Blessed is He and blessed is
His name"—go and examine this.[1]

In this way, one should focus when visiting the
sick that through this act of kindness he is attending
to and visiting the "patients" who are Tiferet and
Malkhut, which are "sick," as it says, "For I am sick
with love." He strengthens and attends to them by
visiting them, as it states, "Sustain me with raisin
cakes, refresh me with apples." These are found in
Gedulah and Gevurah (the two "raisin cakes") and
in Netzach and Hod (the two "apples"), as explained
in the Tikkunim. Similarly, when a person engages
in this commandment, he causes strength and power
to flow from there, just as he strengthens the sick
person with his visit and alleviates the force of evil
illness, as mentioned.

The healing of the sick occurs because when a
person is weighed down by illness, he acknowledges
in that illness that an external force rules over him,
as stated regarding Job, "Behold, he is in your hand."
Every illness in the world is a spirit of impurity
clothed in judgment upon the person.[2] Through
this, the spiritual blemish descends from above,
and the holy dwelling place is sanctified from the
darkness that darkened the place where his soul is
attached. This is the meaning of "You are righteous
concerning all that comes upon us."

The illness being an evil force given to make one
sick is why it is said that they are "faithful to those

[1] The phrase 'פוק עיין' is a Talmudic expression literally meaning 'go out and see/examine,' used to direct the reader to investigate a matter further.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic worldview that physical ailments are manifestations of spiritual realities, specifically the result of divine judgment (din) taking physical form through the channels of spiritual impurity.

[i] The author uses a nursing mother as a metaphor for how blessings function—just as an infant's nursing increases the mother's milk production, our prayers and blessings increase divine flow in the spiritual realms.

[ii] This refers to the twelve-letter Divine Name, a mystical concept in Kabbalah used in prayer and meditation.

[iii] The author interprets illness in kabbalistic terms, suggesting that the divine attributes of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) and Malkhut (Kingdom) are in a state of metaphysical 'illness' or separation that requires healing through human actions.

[iv] The text presents a mystical understanding of disease as the manifestation of spiritual impurity clothed in divine judgment, rather than merely natural physical processes.

נתקע בו עד יקבל מאריה חובא
דידיה והיינו ממש שאותה נשמה
במקומה העליון נשפט עליה דין
ומחיין לה בפולסי דנורא וזה
גורם הקדחת לגוף ואם מכח
הדין המגליד הקשה אז גורם
השחפת בגוף. ומיחושים יורו
פגם מה בחלק נשמתו אשר יכאב
האבר ההוא ולכן אמרו כל
מיחוש ולא מיחוש ראש כי בראש
עקר משכן הנשמה ומורה גודל
עונו וכן באיבת הלב מסוכן. כי
מורה שהפגם הוא בתוכיותה של
הנפש ששם משכנה ולכן אמרו
כל כאב ולא כאב לב. אך עקר
המלקות העליון הוא באש ולכן
האי אישתא צמירתא פרונקא
דמלאכא דמותא היא[i] ורוב
המתים הקדחת מכלה אותם: לכן
אמרו בפרשת בשלח דף קס״ד
דכל אורחוי דש״מ בתסקופא
אינון דא בעינא ודא לא בעינא
מכח החצוני השולט בו ובנשמתו
ובהיות האדם בא לבקר אותו
ומיצר עליו ומבקש עליו רחמים
מושך על אותה נשמה שפע מצד
הכתר והיינו רופא חולים כי
מרפא הנשמה ומיחד ת״ת עם
בינה ששם מציאות נפש רוח
ונשמה מלובשים בדין ובחולי.
ובבקרו ובשומו עליו עינו לטוב
גורם גילוי הספירות העליונות
על החולה שהיא השכינה למעלה
מראשותיו ובבקש עליו רחמים
בתוך חולי עמו ישראל מייחד
ומיקל חליו. ובקור חולים הוא
מצד מדת החסד. ואם מתעסק
ברפואתו עולה עד אריך אנפין
שמשם מושך ארוכה ומרפא ולכן

who send them"—that judgment is embedded in him until he receives from his Master the debt that is his. This literally means that the soul in its supernal place is judged, and it is struck with lashes of fire,[1] which causes fever in the body. If it comes from the hardened, severe judgment, then it causes consumption in the body. Physical ailments indicate some blemish in the part of his soul corresponding to the painful limb. Therefore, they said, "Any pain but not head pain," because the head is the primary dwelling place of the soul and indicates the magnitude of one's sin. Similarly, heart pain is dangerous because it shows that the blemish is in the innermost part of the soul, where it dwells. Therefore, they said, "Any pain but not heart pain." However, the primary heavenly punishment is through fire, which is why this intense fever is the messenger of the Angel of Death, and most deaths are caused by fever consuming them.

Therefore, they said in Parshat Beshalach, page 164, that all the ways of the Angel of Death are with affliction—"I want this, I don't want that"—due to the external force ruling over him and his soul. When a person comes to visit him, feels distress for him, and seeks mercy for him, he draws divine flow from the aspect of Keter to that soul. This is the meaning of "healer of the sick," for he heals the soul and unifies Tiferet with Binah, where the existence of Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah are clothed in judgment and illness. By visiting and setting his eye upon him for good, he causes the revelation of the supernal Sefirot upon the sick person,[2] which is the Divine Presence above his head. By seeking mercy for him among the sick of Israel, he creates unity and alleviates his illness. Visiting the sick comes from the attribute of Chesed (Loving-kindness). If one actively engages in healing him, it ascends all the way to Arich Anpin, from where he draws healing and remedy. Therefore, the charity of supporting the sick

95R 100R 105R 110R 115R 120R 125R 130R

[1] The phrase 'פולסי דנורא' (lashes of fire) appears in rabbinic literature as a form of heavenly punishment that has consequences in the physical world, connecting spiritual judgment to physical suffering.

[2] The text presents visiting the sick as creating a connection between the human and divine realms, specifically causing the divine presence (Shekhinah) to dwell above the sick person's head, bringing healing energy.

[i] The concept that fever is the 'messenger of the Angel of Death' reflects the traditional Jewish understanding that fevers were particularly dangerous forms of illness, seen as direct manifestations of divine judgment.

צדקת פרנסת החולים קודמת לכל שאר צדקה [i]

takes precedence over all other forms of charity.

כי ממשיך מכתר נשמה לכל
135 הספירות. ישתדל החולה לקיים
המצות שבכחו ואונו[ii] כי אז
נשקלים כל עונותיו. כתב
הרב רבי יצחק דמן עכו
מעשה היה ברב רבינו יוסף
140 גיקטי"ליא[iii] שחלה עד קרוב
למיתה ונים ולא נים תיר
ולא תיר[iv] ראה ב' אנשים
שוקלין עונותיו וזכיותיו
במאזנים[v] שוקלים שוה בשוה
145 מיד נתעורר ונתחזק ושאל
התפלין ושם אותם ומיד התחיל

For it draws down a soul from Keter to all the sefirot.[1] The sick person should strive to fulfill the commandments within his strength and vigor,[A] for then all his sins are weighed. Rabbi Isaac of Acre wrote that there was an incident with Rabbi Joseph Gikatilla, who became ill to the point of near death. While in a state of semi-consciousness, neither fully asleep nor fully awake,[B] he saw two men weighing his sins and merits on scales that were balanced equally. Immediately, he awoke and strengthened himself,[2] asked for his tefillin, put them on, and at once began to recover, rising from death to life,[3] because he tipped the scales in favor of his

135R

140R

145R

[A] Or: "according to his ability and energy" — This alternative is more colloquial and may be more immediately comprehensible to modern readers, though it loses some of the biblical resonance of the original terms.

[B] Or: "in a twilight state between sleep and wakefulness" — This more poetic rendering captures the liminal nature of the state while being more concise, though it's less literal.

[1] This kabbalistic concept describes the flow of divine energy from Keter (the highest sefirah) through the system of divine emanations. The text suggests that proper care for the sick facilitates this cosmic process.

[2] The narrative demonstrates the kabbalistic principle that physical actions (putting on tefillin) have direct metaphysical effects (tipping the scales of judgment).

[3] This phrase uses resurrection imagery to describe recovery from illness, reflecting the Jewish theological understanding of healing as a form of resurrection on a small scale.

[i] Cf. Song of Songs 2:5 — The verse 'Sustain me with raisin cakes, refresh me with apples' is interpreted kabbalistically as referring to the divine emanations (sefirot) and how they provide spiritual sustenance. The author maps these foods to specific divine attributes: raisin cakes to Gedulah and Gevurah, and apples to Netzach and Hod. | Cf. Song of Songs 2:5 — The phrase 'For I am sick with love' is interpreted as referring to the divine attributes of Tiferet and Malkhut being in a state of 'illness' or separation that requires 'healing' through human acts of kindness like visiting the sick. | Cf. Job 2:6 — The reference to Job ('Behold, he is in your hand') connects physical illness to spiritual causes, specifically the permission given to external forces to afflict a person, while maintaining that this ultimately serves divine purposes. | Cf. Zohar, Beshalach 164 — The Zohar passage describes how the Angel of Death operates with affliction and capriciousness ('I want this, I don't want that'), explaining the seemingly random nature of illness as actually being the work of external spiritual forces. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The reference to 'Tikkunim' refers to Tikkunei Zohar, a major kabbalistic text that explores the correspondences between biblical verses, divine names, and the sefirot (divine emanations). The text is cited as the source for the interpretation of the raisin cakes and apples as specific divine attributes.

[ii] The text emphasizes that the sick person should fulfill commandments to the extent of their ability, showing Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on continued religious practice even during illness.

[iii] Rabbi Joseph Gikatilla (c. 1248-c. 1325) was a prominent Spanish kabbalist, known for works such as Sha'arei Orah (Gates of Light), a systematic presentation of kabbalistic symbolism.

[iv] This Aramaic expression describes a state between sleep and wakefulness, semi-consciousness. The redundant phrasing ('asleep yet not asleep, awake yet not awake') emphasizes the liminal nature of this state, considered particularly receptive to spiritual communications.

[v] The image of weighing sins and merits on scales appears throughout rabbinic literature and reflects the belief that divine judgment involves a precise accounting of one's actions.

להרפא ועלה ממות לחיים
כי הכריע כף הזכיות. וישית
החולה לב לחלומותיו ובפרט
אם הוא ת״ח שכמה פעמים
מראים לו להודיעו את אשר נגזר
עליו ובמה יזכה ארחו.[i] ע״ד
שאמרו במדרש שיר השירים
כל חלאים שאתה מביא עלי
בשביל להאהבני לך על פסוק
כי חולת אהבה אני.[ii] וזה דבר
מאומת וידוע אצל קצת אנשי
המעלה.[iii] אמרי׳ במדרש קהלת
בשם ר׳ יהושע בן לוי שכל
החולים בחזקת סכנה הם. וכן
אמרו בגמרין עלה למטה וכו׳.
עוד שם דף ע״ד ע״ב המסורה
הזאת תהיה בידך כל העושה
מצוה סמוך למיתתו[iv] דומה שלא
היתה צדקתו חסירה כי אם אותה
מצוה והשלימה וכל העובר
עבירה סמוך למיתתו דומה
שלא היתה מדת רשעתו חסירה
אלא אותה עבירה והשלימה
אלו ואלו הולכין ושלמין אלו
שלמין במדת צדקן ואלו שלמין
במדת רשען רחמנא ליצלן.

merits.[A] The sick person should pay attention to his dreams,[1] especially if he is a Torah scholar, for many times things are shown to him to inform him of what has been decreed upon him and how he might merit his path. This follows what they said in the Midrash on Song of Songs regarding the verse "For I am lovesick"—"All illnesses that You bring upon me are to make me beloved to You."[B2] This is a verified and known matter among some people of stature.[3] It is said in the Midrash on Ecclesiastes in the name of Rabbi Joshua ben Levi that all sick people are presumed to be in danger. And so they said in our Gemara, "If one takes to his bed, etc." Further, on page 74b, "Keep this tradition: Anyone who performs a mitzvah near his death,[4] it is as if his righteousness was lacking only that mitzvah, which he has now completed. And anyone who commits a transgression near his death, it is as if his wickedness was lacking only that transgression, which he has now completed. Both go forth complete—these complete in their measure of righteousness, and those complete in their measure of wickedness, God forbid." Therefore, a person greatly needs strengthening to purify his deeds and thoughts near his death. All of Israel are guarantors for one another,[C] to be a substantial support for

150R 155R 160R 165R 170R

[A] Or: "the scale of merits outweighed [the scale of sins]" — This alternative is more literal to the Hebrew construction, which focuses on the scale itself rather than the person's action, though both convey the same meaning.

[B] Or: "to increase my love for You" — This alternative interpretation is found in some commentaries, suggesting that illness increases the sufferer's love for God rather than God's love for the person, though the former interpretation is more common in mystical texts.

[C] Or: "All Jews are responsible for one another" — This more contemporary phrasing may be clearer to modern readers, though 'guarantors' more precisely captures the legal concept behind the Hebrew term.

[1] The text presents dreams as a channel for divine communication, especially for Torah scholars, reflecting the kabbalistic understanding that dreams can reveal decrees from the heavenly court.

[2] This mystical interpretation of suffering frames illness not as punishment but as divine love, transforming the experience of the sick person from mere suffering to spiritual refinement.

[3] This phrase suggests that the mystical understanding of illness is part of an esoteric tradition known primarily to spiritual elites with experiential knowledge.

[4] The emphasis on actions near death reflects the book's focus on proper spiritual preparation for the transition between worlds, with final actions having special significance.

[i] This phrase uses biblical language to refer to how one might merit or purify one's path/way of life, echoing Psalm 119:9: 'How can a young man keep his way pure?'

[ii] This quote from Song of Songs 2:5 is interpreted mystically to suggest that physical illness can be an expression of divine love, transforming suffering into a sign of spiritual elevation.

[iii] The phrase 'people of stature' refers to individuals of spiritual distinction who have access to higher forms of knowledge, implying an esoteric tradition known to spiritual elites.

[iv] This teaching emphasizes the spiritual significance of one's final actions, suggesting that the end of life has special weight in determining one's ultimate spiritual status.

על כן מאד צריך חזוק לאדם
לטהר מעשיו ורעיונותיו סמוך
למיתתו. וכל ישראל ערבים
זה לזה[i] להיות לחבירו מסייע
שיש בו ממש ובזה יזכה כי
יחלו פניו רבים ונשמתו תהיה
נתונה באוצר. וכל שאינו מבקר
החולה אמרו במדרש תהלים
מזמור מ״א שגורם להוסיף
לו אחד מששים מחליו[ii] וזה
לדעתי יהיה דוקא בבן גילו.
וכשהחולה מצטער מחליו לימד
רבי חנינא שירגיל עצמו לומר
האל הנאמן[iii] בדאיתא במדרש
שיר השירים רבה דף י״ג ע״ב
דקוב״ה דאיהו רחום טב לא
לחסר טיבותיה מיניה לעלם: [iv]

one's fellow, and through this he will merit that many will entreat on his behalf and his soul will be placed in the treasury.[1] Regarding one who does not visit the sick, they said in the Midrash on Psalms, chapter 41, that he causes one-sixtieth of the illness to be added to the sick person, though in my opinion this applies specifically to someone born under the same astrological sign.[2] And when the sick person suffers from his illness, Rabbi Hanina taught that he should accustom himself to say "The Faithful God,"[3] as is stated in the Midrash Shir HaShirim Rabbah, page 13b: "For the Holy One, blessed be He, who is merciful and good, will never withhold His goodness from him forever."

פרק ט״ו

Chapter 15

ראיתי מי שנוהג בשהנפטר
סמוך למיתתו מסלקים
מלפניו וגם מחדרו קרוביו
הבוכים[v] ואומרים שמצערים
אותו בזה נראה לי סמך למנהג
הלועזים ממה שמצינו במדרש

I have seen that some people have the custom, when someone is near death, to remove from before him and from his room his weeping relatives, saying that they cause him distress. It seems to me that there is support for this custom of non-Jews from what we find in the Midrash HaNe'elam, page 98, that Rabbi

[1] This metaphor of divine treasury refers to the afterlife destination of righteous souls, suggesting that proper community support for the sick helps secure this favorable outcome.

[2] The term 'ben gilo' refers to astrological connection, suggesting that spiritual influences are particularly potent between people with similar celestial configurations.

[3] This practice of repeating divine epithets during illness reflects the kabbalistic belief that divine names connect the person to specific aspects of divine energy that can facilitate healing.

[i] This principle of mutual responsibility ('All Israel are guarantors for one another') appears in various rabbinic texts and forms the theological basis for communal obligations, particularly regarding the care of the sick and dying.

[ii] The fraction 'one-sixtieth' appears frequently in rabbinic literature to represent a minimal but significant amount. Here it suggests that avoiding visitation has real consequences for the sick person.

[iii] This divine epithet ('The Faithful God') comes from Deuteronomy 7:9 and is recommended as a spiritual practice for the sick, reflecting the belief that divine names have healing properties when invoked with proper intention.

[iv] Cf. Midrash Shir HaShirim Rabbah — This reference frames suffering as spiritually beneficial rather than merely punitive, a core theological concept in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Midrash Kohelet — This establishes the halakhic principle that justifies breaking Shabbat and other commandments to care for the sick. | Cf. Talmudic teaching about final actions — This emphasizes the spiritual importance of final actions, which is why Ma'avar Yabok places such importance on proper preparation for death. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim on Psalm 41 — This frames visiting the sick not merely as a social kindness but as having actual impact on the sick person's condition, reinforcing the mystical efficacy of proper visitation.

[v] The author is discussing a custom to remove crying relatives from the presence of a dying person. He notes this seems like a non-Jewish custom (מנהג הלועזים) but then finds support for it in Jewish mystical literature.

הנעלם דף צ״ח כי ר׳ אליעזר הגדול אמר לבנו שהיה רואה כי במהרה יסתלק מן העולם ואמר לו זיל ואימא לאמך דתסתלק תפלגי באתר עילא ובתר דאסתלק מן עלמא ואתי הכא למחמי לון לא תבכי דאינון קריבין עלאין ולא תתאין ודעתא דבר נש לא ידע בהו. מנהגן של ישראל להדליק נרות בפני הגוסס וטעם לזה נודע כי מדברי חכמים שסגולת הנר הוא להבריח המזיקים ואפי׳ בלילה עת שליטתן כדאמרי׳ אבוקה כשנים ולכן בעור החמץ והמחמצת שהם ס״מ ולילית שמהם יצר הרע וכחותיו הוא בכח אור נר כי יחל עליהם כי נר אור רשעים ידעך ונגלל בנוקבא דתהומא רבא חשך מפני אור וכל שכן שתועיל ביום לשבר מלתעות עול ולהניס אותם החוצה כי שלהבת הנר רומזו ליחוד עליון שלכן אמר הכתוב נר ה׳ נשמת אדם. וממנו נראה הנפש בגוף על ידי רביעית דם שבלב שבו שורה נפש החיונית[i] וכן מתראה כנר קשור רוח בנפש ונשמה ברוח כי כמו שהנפש הוא התעוררות תחתון המתדבק בגוף כן אור תחתון מהנר שהוא כגוון תכלת שחור מתדבקת בפתילה ונעשה כסא לאור עליון הלבן השורה על אותו אור שחור כמו שהנפש נעשית כסא לשרות עליו רוח ממרום אור לבן ומלובן וכמו שבנר כשמתקנים ב׳ אורות אליו מתראה עליהם אור סתום שאין לו גוון כלל ונראה לעין כל מכל הגוונים ולא נדע מאי דשרי על ההוא אור לבן. על דרך זה הנשמה הסתומה העליונה מתראית ומוצאה מנוח על הרוח והנפש והיא נעשית כסא לגבי אור עליון שעליה נשמת הנשמות ועין מזה

Eliezer the Great said to his son, when he saw that he would soon depart from the world: “Go and tell your mother to remove herself to a higher place, and after I depart from the world and come here to see them, do not weep, for neither those above nor those below, nor human understanding, knows about them.” 10R

It is the custom of Israel to light candles before a dying person. The reason for this is known from the words of the Sages, that the special property of a candle is to drive away harmful spirits, even at night when they rule, as they said, “A torch is equivalent to two people.” Therefore, in burning chametz and leaven, which represent Samael and Lilith, from whom come the evil inclination and its powers, it is done with the power of candlelight that shines upon them, for “the lamp of the wicked will be extinguished” and darkness is rolled into the great abyss before light. How much more effective it is during the day to break the jaws of wickedness and drive them outside, for the flame of the candle alludes to the supernal unification. That is why Scripture says, “The soul of man is the lamp of the Lord.” 15R 20R 25R

Through this, the soul becomes visible in the body by means of the quarter-measure of blood in the heart, where the vital soul resides. Similarly, the spirit appears as a flame bound to the soul, and the higher soul to the spirit. Just as the soul is a lower arousal that attaches to the body, so too the lower light of the candle, which is like a blue-black color, attaches to the wick and becomes a throne for the upper white light that rests upon that black light. Similarly, the soul becomes a throne for the spirit from on high, a white and purified light. And just as in a candle, when two lights are prepared for it, a concealed light appears above them that has no color at all and appears to every eye as containing all colors, though we do not know what rests upon that white light. In this way, the concealed, supernal soul appears and finds rest upon the spirit and the soul, and it becomes a throne for the supernal light above it, the soul of souls. See this in Parashat Lech Lecha and in many other places. This is an allusion to the three names interwoven together: Ehyeh, YHVH, and Adonut, whose numerical value is Yabok, representing the secret of soul, spirit, and higher soul. The three lights mentioned appear in the three colors of 30R 35R 40R 45R 50R

[i] This reflects the rabbinic understanding that the vital soul (nefesh chiyunit) resides in the blood, specifically in the heart, based on Leviticus 17:11, ‘For the life of the flesh is in the blood.’

פרשת לך לך ובהרבה מקומות
אחרים וזהו רמז לשלש שמות
המשולבים יחד אהי״ה הוי״ה
אדנו״ת מספרם יב״ק בסוד
נפש רוח נשמה[i] ושלש מאורות
הנזכר מתראים בג׳ גווני העין
ונכללים כלם במלכות הנקראת
אישון ובת עין ומזה נוכל למצא
טעם למנהג הדלקת האבוקות
למתים שהוא יחוד ושמירה
אליהם ואמרי׳ בגמרא שעשויה
לכבוד ירצה להאיר וליחד
עליהם הל״ב נתיבות בגי׳ כבו״ד
המסלקות כל חיצוני ומחיות
הכל. עוד יורה כי מסתלקים
מנפש הנפטר המדרגות המאירים
בחול ובהנהגת מטטרון עץ הדעת
טוב ורע הנקרא מאורי האש
כשהם במקום זוהמת הצפרנים
רמז להשפעות המתראות בעולם
הזה[ii] שהוא עולם הכליון בסוד
התכלית שתמיד שורף הפתילה
והשמן או השעוה. והנה הוא
מוכן לקבל ולהאיר נשמתו
מסוד הנהגת השבת הנקראים
מאורי אור. עוד יורה כי בזה
מתייחדים מאורי האש במאורי
אור שסלוק צדיק זה מייחד
עולם היצירה שבו מאורי האש
עם עולם הבריאה שבו מאורי
חור[iii] ובזה מתעלה הכבוד
העליון וזהו נר של מתים העשוי
לכבוד על דרך ובהיכלו כלו
אומר כבוד. למען יזמרך כבוד
ועיין בפרשת בראשית חלוק
שבין מאורי האור למאורי האש
וטעם לזה אנו מברכים בכל מ״ש
ויוה״כ בורא מאורי האש ובזה
ובשאר צרכיו הנעשים לנפטר

the eye, and they are all included in Malchut, which is called the pupil and the daughter of the eye.

From this we can find a reason to praise the custom of lighting torches for the dead, which serves as unification and protection for them. They say in the Gemara that it is made for honor, meaning to illuminate and unify upon them the 32 paths, which has the numerical value of "honor" (kavod), which remove all external forces and give life to all. This further indicates that the levels that illuminate during weekdays under the governance of Metatron—the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, called "the luminaries of fire" when they are in the place of the impurity of the fingernails—are departing from the soul of the deceased, alluding to the influences that appear in this world, which is the world of destruction, in the secret of purpose, which constantly burns the wick and the oil or wax.

And behold, the deceased is prepared to receive and illuminate his soul from the secret of Sabbath governance, called "the luminaries of light." This further indicates that through this, the luminaries of fire unite with the luminaries of light, for the departure of this righteous person unifies the World of Formation, which contains the luminaries of fire, with the World of Creation, which contains the luminaries of light, and through this the supernal honor is elevated. This is the candle for the dead made for honor, as in the verse "In His temple, all proclaim glory." That "glory may sing praises to You." See in Parashat Bereshit the distinction between the luminaries of light and the luminaries of fire, and the reason why we bless "Who creates the luminaries of fire" on every Saturday night and Yom Kippur. Through this and other needs performed for the deceased, as will be explained, we arouse mercy for him through action, speech, and thoughts of the heart.

From here, the discerning person can find a praiseworthy reason for the custom of lighting

55R 60R 65R 70R 75R 80R 85R 90R

[i] This is a key passage explaining the mystical significance of the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok.' The numerical value of these three divine names equals the value of Yabok (יב״ק = 112), and these correspond to the three levels of the soul involved in the death transition.

[ii] The author uses the kabbalistic concept of 'impurity of the fingernails' (zohama of the nails) as a symbol for the physical, mundane influences that must be shed at death. In kabbalah, the fingernails represent the outermost extension of the body where impurity can collect.

[iii] The author presents a complex kabbalistic understanding where the death of a righteous person creates a unification between different spiritual worlds—specifically the World of Formation (Yetzirah) and the World of Creation (Beriah). This reflects the belief that human death has cosmic significance.

כמו שיבא מעוררים רחמים עליו
בעובדא ומלולא ובהרהורא
דלבא. ומכאן יוכל המשכיל
למצא טעם לשבח למנהג הנר
שמדליקים על המתים במקומו
בשבעת הימים כי בה אית נייחא
לנשמתא ודאי וכן בכל י״ב
חדש בבתי כנסיות שהוא זמן
שכלה גופו בקרקע ונשמתו
נדונת אז ועולה ויורדת בנדרש
בזהר פרשת חיי שרה. ועם הנר
שמדליקין על הגוסס מצרפים
להביט בפניו כדי להאיר לו
מבת עין העליונה בסוד גווני
האור על דרך עיני ה׳ אלהיך
בה למתקה ולבסמה ולכן גם
בשעת התפלה עת יחוד מלכות
שהיא עיקר ההנהגה אלינו
וצריכים אנו ליחדה עם גג״ת
גווני העין העליונים בסוד ש״ן
בי״ת צריך שיתן עיניו למטה
ובזה יהיה מלכות לב העולם
למעלה כמשל אבן הקאלאמי״טה
השואבת ובזה מאירים ארץ חפץ
דלית לה מגרמה כלום וכן כתיב
והיו עיני ולבי שם כל הימים.
עוד נ״ר דלו״ק בגימטריא
השכינ״ה[i] שהיא מוכנת לקבל
אור עליון והיא העששית שכל
הגוונים מתראים מתוכה ואחר
קבלת האור תקרא נר ה׳ וכן נר
מצוה כי מצוה הוא שם בן ארבע
כנודע וג׳ מאורות שבנר כנזכר
הם מצד הגבורה כי השכינה
היא דולקת לפני הת״ת מצד
הגבורה וזהו תחלת ההתעוררות
אל היחוד בסוד שמאלו תחת
לראשי:[ii]

a candle for the dead in their place during the seven days of mourning, for it certainly provides comfort to the soul. Similarly, throughout the twelve months in synagogues, which is the time when the body has decomposed in the ground and the soul is being judged, ascending and descending, as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Chayei Sarah. With the candle that we light for the dying person, we combine looking at his face to illuminate him from the supernal pupil of the eye, in the secret of the colors of light, as in "The eyes of the Lord your God are upon it," to sweeten and perfume it. Therefore, also during prayer, the time of unification of Malchut, which is the main governance for us, we need to unify it with the colors of the supernal eye in the secret of Shin and Bet, one must direct one's eyes downward, and through this, Malchut will be the heart of the world above, like the example of the lodestone that attracts, and through this we illuminate the Land of Desire, which has nothing of its own, as it is written, "And My eyes and My heart shall be there all the days."

Furthermore, "lamp" (ner) "kindled" (daluk) in gematria equals "the Divine Presence" (HaShechinah), which is prepared to receive supernal light, and it is the lantern through which all colors appear, and after receiving the light, it is called "the lamp of the Lord" and also "the lamp of commandment," for "commandment" is a four-letter name, as is known. And the three lights in the lamp, as mentioned, are from the side of Gevurah, for the Divine Presence burns before Tiferet from the side of Gevurah, and this is the beginning of arousal to unification, in the secret of "His left hand is under my head."

95R 100R 105R 110R 115R 120R 125R

[i] The author uses gematria (Hebrew numerology) to show that 'ner daluk' (kindled lamp) has the same numerical value as 'HaShechinah' (the Divine Presence), reinforcing the connection between physical candles and spiritual illumination.

[ii] Cf. Midrash HaNe'elam — This reference establishes an authoritative basis for a seemingly non-Jewish custom by rooting it in kabbalistic literature, suggesting that the author is seeking to integrate or validate various customs within a Jewish mystical framework. | Cf. נשמת נר ה אדם — This reference connects the physical practice of lighting candles with the metaphysical understanding of the human soul as God's light in the world, creating a symbolic correspondence between ritual action and spiritual reality. | Cf. מאורי אור and מאורי האש — The author is using these liturgical concepts to elaborate a complex kabbalistic interpretation where physical candles facilitate the unification of different spiritual worlds and the elevation of the soul through various levels of divine illumination. | Cf. רבינית דם שבלב — This reference connects the physiological

פרק ט״ז

Chapter 16

ברוך אשר לו נתכנו עלילות והכתיב בתורתו כי ביום אכלך ממנו מות תמות כי טעם המיתה היא רחמנות ותקון והיא מלשון תמימות ודא בגין דיתמחי יצר הרע דבגויה כדפירשו בזהר על פסוק ופגריכם אתם יפלו במדבר הזה. וזהו והנה טוב מאד זה מות[i] כי אברי האדם ביום ברוא אלהים אדם על הארץ הם רמז לדברים רוחניים: והאדם הוא צל העליונים ואפילו הרמת ידו מתראה למעלה שכל אבריו ועורקיו וגידיו בפרט וצורתו בכלל נרמזים למעלה בדאיתא בר״מ פרשת בהר סיני ובתוכם האלהות נסתר ונגלה בנראה מר׳ אלעזר בר׳ שמעון וממעשה דר׳ דכל בי שמשי הוה אתי לביתיה.[ii] וסטרא דמסאבותא הוא המגשים הרוחני. נמצא כי הסתרת נפש האדם בגוף כהסתרת מדה אחת במה שלמטה ממנה בספירות העליונות.

Blessed is He to whom all designs are attributed,[1] who wrote in His Torah: "For on the day you eat of it, you shall surely die." The purpose of death is mercy and rectification,[2] and it derives from the word "completeness," for it is meant to erase the evil inclination within, as explained in the Zohar on the verse "And your carcasses shall fall in this wilderness." This is the meaning of "And behold, it was very good"—this refers to death. For a person's limbs, on the day God created man upon the earth, are symbolic of spiritual matters. 5R 10R

Man is a shadow of the supernal beings, and even the raising of his hand is reflected above, as all his limbs, veins, and sinews individually, and his form as a whole, are represented above, as stated in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Behar Sinai. The Divine presence is both concealed and revealed within them, as evident from Rabbi Eleazar, son of Rabbi Shimon, and from the account of Rabbi [Judah the Prince], who would come to his home every Sabbath eve after his death. The side of impurity is what materializes the spiritual. Thus, the concealment of a person's soul within the body is like the concealment of one divine attribute within what is below it[3] in the su- 15R 20R

[1] The opening phrase 'ברוך אשר לו נתכנו עלילות' echoes 1 Samuel 2:3 from Hannah's prayer, which praises God as the one who weighs or measures all actions. The author begins with this praise of divine providence to establish that even death is part of God's purposeful design.

[2] This central theological claim of the passage presents death not as punishment but as divine mercy ('רחמנות') and rectification ('תקון'). This positive view of death stands in contrast to how it is often understood, framing it instead as part of the divine plan for human perfection.

[3] This passage articulates a fundamental kabbalistic principle of correspondence between human and divine structures. Just as divine emanations (sefirot) are 'clothed' or concealed within lower emanations, the human soul is 'clothed' within the body, establishing a microcosm-macrocosm relationship.

understanding of life (blood in the heart) with mystical concepts about the soul's residence in the body, showing how the author integrates medical and spiritual understandings of human existence. | Cf. אה״ה הוי״ה אדנו״ת — This reference establishes a direct connection between the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' and these divine names, suggesting that the transition of death is a journey through these three levels of soul, facilitated by divine presence represented by these names. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Chayei Sarah — This reference grounds the custom of lighting memorial candles for twelve months in authoritative mystical literature, showing how ritual practice corresponds to the soul's journey after death as described in the Zohar.

[i] This refers to a rabbinic interpretation of Genesis 1:31, where "very good" is interpreted as referring to death. In Genesis Rabbah 9:5, Rabbi Meir's Torah scroll reportedly had the phrase "behold, it was very good" followed by "behold, death was good"—indicating that death serves a positive purpose in the divine plan.

[ii] The text references two Talmudic accounts where the divine presence was revealed through deceased sages. The first refers to Rabbi Eleazar, son of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, whose body did not decay after death (Bava Metzia 84b). The second refers to Rabbi Judah the Prince, who would return to his home every Sabbath eve after his death, as recounted in Ketubbot 103a.

ועל זה נאמר וייצר ה׳ אלהים
את האדם ויפח בי שני שמות
אלו הם נרתק זה לזה ונשמת
האדם מאירה בתוכו כאור
המזהיר בספיר. וכאשר עצב
רוח קדשו הוזקק למיתה דשם
סטרא דמסאבותא ונטמן בעפר
כי נחש עפר לחמו והטומאה
מתמעטת ויצר הרע נגדע. ועם
היות המות מסטרא דרע מאחר
שבה יתבטל הרע הנה היא הטוב
על הדרך מי יתן טהור מטמא לא
אחד. והמיתה הנאמרת בתורה
אם לא יחטא אדם יהיה פי׳ אדם
כי ימות באהל והשאר המיתות
הנזכרות בה במיתת המלכין
קדמאין דאינון עולמות שעלו
במחשבה[i] שהיא חכמה להבראות
ומרוב האור אצטנעו ורמזו סוד
עמוק זה בפ׳ ואלה המלכים אשר
מלכו בארץ אדום ופי׳ באידרא
ובספרא דצניעותא לאו דמיתו
אלא דאצטנעו ונתעלו למעלה
אל מקורם. וזהו בונה עולמות
ומחריבן כי עולמות רוצה
לומר סדר זמנים שהוא מחסד
ולמטה. ומחריבן ירצה מסתיר
אותם בסיבתן העליונה. ומורי
מפאנו זצ״ל הביא בדרושיו
מה היתה המיתה הזאת קודם
החטא[ii] יעויין שם וגורי האר״י
זצו״קל בהקדמותיהם הראשונות
דברו מזה על אזן שומעת. ועיין

pernal emanations. 25R

Regarding this, it is written: "And the LORD God formed man... and breathed," for these two divine names are sheaths for each other, and a person's soul illuminates within him like light shining through sapphire. When His holy spirit was grieved, 30R death became necessary, for there lies the side of impurity, and it is buried in dust, for "dust is the serpent's food." Thus impurity is diminished and the evil inclination is cut off. Although death comes from the side of evil, since through it evil is nullified, 35R it is good, in accordance with "Who can bring purity from impurity? Is it not the One?"

The death mentioned in the Torah, had man not sinned, would be interpreted as "when a man dies in a tent," while the other deaths mentioned 40R refer to the "death of the primordial kings"—those worlds that arose in thought, which is Wisdom, to be created, but due to the overwhelming light, they were concealed. This profound secret is alluded to in the passage "These are the kings who reigned 45R in the land of Edom," and is explained in the Idra and Safra D'Tzniuta that they did not actually die but were concealed and elevated back to their source.[A] This is the meaning of "He builds worlds and destroys them"[1]—"worlds" referring to the 50R order of times, which extends from Chesed (Loving-kindness) downward, and "destroys them" meaning He conceals them in their supernal cause.

My teacher from Fano, of blessed memory,[B] elaborated in his discourses on what this death was before 55R the sin—see there—and the disciples of the ARI, may the memory of the holy righteous one be a blessing,

[A] Or: "in the Idra and Safra D'Tzniuta that they did not die but rather were concealed and elevated upward to their source" — This translation better captures the nuance of 'לאו דמיתו אלא דאצטנעו' by emphasizing the contrast with 'rather' and follows the Hebrew word order more closely.

[B] Or: "And my teacher from Fano, of blessed memory" — Adding the conjunction 'And' preserves the flow from the previous sentence in the original Hebrew, which begins with 'ו' (and).

[1] This refers to a rabbinic statement in Genesis Rabbah 3:7 and 9:2 that God created and destroyed multiple worlds before creating ours. The kabbalistic interpretation provided here reframes 'destruction' as 'concealment,' suggesting these worlds were not eliminated but rather reabsorbed into their divine source.

[i] This refers to a kabbalistic concept that interprets Genesis 36:31-39 (the kings who ruled in Edom) as referring to primordial worlds that existed and were 'shattered' before our current world. These are known as the 'broken vessels' or 'shattered kings' in Lurianic Kabbalah.

[ii] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano (1548-1620), an Italian kabbalist and philosopher who wrote extensively on the nature of the universe according to Lurianic Kabbalah. The 'death before sin' he discusses likely refers to the spiritual transformation that would have occurred had humans not sinned.

עוד בתקונים תקון ס״ו על איזה
אדם נאמר אדם כי ימות באהל.
ובזה נבין אומרו יתברך ועתה
פן ישלח ידו ולקח גם מעץ
החיים ואכל וחי לעולם והפך זה
דבר על יד נביאו ובחרת בחיים
אלא אם יחיה בעודו ביצר הרע
ודאי ימות מיתה נפשית ועתה
במותו יחיה כי נחית לעפרא
בגין דיתמחי יצר הרע דבגויה
ולזה גורש מגן עדן שלא יאכל
מעץ החיים וכל מדותיו יתברך
אפי׳ הנראים לכתחלה דין הם
רחמים על ברואיו כי חפץ חסד
הוא ועיין מזה פרשת פקודי דף
רמ״ב ובזה יצא לנו טעם לשבח
על גלותינו. עיין בר״מ ויערב
לך ומשם מתבאר למעיין בו למה
הוצרכנו למשניות ובברייתות
בעת הזה ועיין פרשת פקודי דף
רנ״ז מסוד המשנה והברייתא:
ומצאתי להראב״ד בפי׳ משנה
ג׳ מפ״ד מספר יצירה כיצד
המליך אות ב׳ בחיים וקשר לו
כתר וצר בו שבתאי בעולם ויום
ראשון בשנה ועין ימין בנפש
ואמר כי שבתאי הוא ממונה על
החרבן לפי שאינו חפץ בענייני
הגוף ולכן מחריבן ואינו משגיח
בקישוטן אלא על השכלים
הפשוטים ועל השגת הש״י ועל
השגת השביעית והוא ממונה על
החלאים והמות ובית הסוהר
והדלות והקלון והחרפה מזה
העולם דוקא ועל כל עבוב.
ובסוף כתב ולהיותו ממונה על

spoke of this in their early teachings for the attentive ear.[A] See also Tikkunei Zohar, Tikkun 66, regarding which "man" is referred to in "when a man dies in a tent." With this, we can understand God's statement, "And now, lest he put forth his hand and take also from the Tree of Life, and eat, and live forever," which seems contrary to what He said through His prophet, "And you shall choose life." However, if one lives while still possessed of the evil inclination, he will certainly suffer a spiritual death,[1] whereas in his physical death, he shall live, for he descends to the dust so that the evil inclination within him may be erased. This is why he was expelled from the Garden of Eden, so he would not eat from the Tree of Life. All of God's attributes, even those that initially appear as judgment, are merciful toward His creations, for He desires kindness. Examine this in Parashat Pekudei, page 242, and from this we derive a reason to praise our exile. See Ra'aya Mehemna, and it will be pleasant for you, and from there it becomes clear to the student why we needed the Mishnah and Baraita in this time. See also Parashat Pekudei, page 257, on the secret of the Mishnah and Baraita.

60R 65R 70R 75R 80R

I found in RABD's commentary on Mishnah 3, Chapter 4, of Sefer Yetzirah: "How did He enthrone the letter Bet with life, bound a crown to it, and through it formed Saturn in the universe, Sunday in the year, and the right eye in the person?" He states that Saturn is appointed over destruction[2] because it has no interest in bodily matters, and therefore destroys them and does not supervise their adornment, but rather oversees the simple intellects, the perception of God, and the perception of the seventh [attribute]. It is appointed over illnesses, death, imprisonment, poverty, disgrace, and shame specifically in this world, and over all delays. At the end,

85R 90R

[A] Or: "and the disciples of the ARI, may the memory of the holy righteous one be a blessing, discussed this in their introductory works for those with discerning ears" — This alternative more directly translates 'הקדמותיהם' as introductory works rather than 'early teachings', and 'אזן שומעת' might be better rendered as 'discerning ears' to capture the idiom of selective revelation to those capable of understanding.

[1] This passage resolves the apparent contradiction between God preventing access to the Tree of Life (Genesis 3:22) and the commandment to 'choose life' (Deuteronomy 30:19). The author argues that eternal physical life with the evil inclination would result in spiritual death, while physical death enables spiritual purification and true life.

[2] This section integrates astrological concepts with Jewish mysticism, attributing to Saturn (שבתאי) dominion over destruction, illness, death, imprisonment, and poverty, but also over wisdom, knowledge, and Sabbath-observance. This reflects medieval Jewish astrological thought that viewed celestial bodies as channels for divine influence rather than independent powers.

החכמות והדעת הוא ממונה
על שומרי שבת ולפיכך הם
בצרה בזה העולם[i] ע״כ. ואם
קבלה נקבל והאריך בפרטי
ממשלותיו יע״ש בדף ע״ט ופ׳.
וגם הבוטריל האריך בשבח
רוכב שבתאי ואיקלים שלו בשם
הרב ר׳ ברוך מקובל גדול בספר
הנקרא חשן משפט. עוד בזהר
דף רנ״ח גם כן נתן טעם לשבח
גלות וגם בפרשת תצוה דף ק״צ
יש משל ונמשל נאה על זה ולמה
לא היתה גאולה שלימה בבית
שני: [ii]

he wrote that because it is appointed over wisdom and knowledge, it is also appointed over Sabbath-observers, and therefore they are in distress in this world. If this is a received tradition, we accept it. He elaborated on the details of its dominions—see there on pages 79 and 80. Butril also elaborated in praise of the rider of Saturn and its climates, citing Rabbi Baruch, a great Kabbalist, in the book called Choshen Mishpat. Additionally, in the Zohar, page 258, a reason is given to praise exile, and in Parashat Tetzaveh, page 190, there is a beautiful parable and its interpretation on this topic, and on why there was not a complete redemption in the Second Temple period.

ובזה נדע למה שבר משה רבינו
ע״ה הלוחות שהיה בדי לבטל
החירות ממ״ה ומגלות[iii] כטעם
מניעת עץ החיים מאדם הראשון
ולא נבנה בית המקדש בימי משה

Through this we can understand why Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, broke the tablets—it was to nullify freedom from the Angel of Death and from exile,[1] similar to the reason for preventing the first man from accessing the Tree of Life. The

[1]The author presents the breaking of the tablets as a spiritually necessary act, arguing that possessing the intact tablets would have granted Israel a premature immortality and freedom from exile that would have prevented their spiritual development. This interpretation transforms Moses' seemingly destructive act into one of profound spiritual protection.

[i]This presents a mystical explanation for why Sabbath observers might experience worldly difficulties—their spiritual connection to Saturn, which governs both wisdom and worldly suffering. This paradox—that spiritual elevation may coincide with material hardship—is a recurring theme in Jewish mystical thought.

[ii]Cf. Zohar — The author cites the Zohar's interpretation of the verse in Numbers to support his theological claim that death serves a positive spiritual purpose as a means of erasing the evil inclination from within the person. | Cf. Genesis 1:31 — The author draws on a rabbinic interpretation that "very good" refers to death, suggesting that death, despite its apparent negativity, serves a positive purpose in the divine plan. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna (Zohar) — The author cites this text to support the kabbalistic concept that the human form mirrors spiritual realities, with each part of the body corresponding to divine attributes. | Cf. Genesis 36:31 — The author refers to the kabbalistic interpretation of this passage as describing primordial spiritual worlds that existed and were 'destroyed' before our current world order, using it to explain the concept of death before sin. | Cf. Idra and Safra D'Tzniuta — The author cites these authoritative kabbalistic texts to explain that the 'death' of primordial worlds was not actual destruction but a process of concealment and elevation back to their divine source. | Cf. Genesis 3:22-24 — The author interprets this as a merciful act, preventing humans from living eternally with the evil inclination, which would result in spiritual death. Physical death thus becomes a means to spiritual purification and true life. | Cf. Deuteronomy 30:19 — The author contrasts this with God's prevention of Adam accessing the Tree of Life, resolving the apparent contradiction by explaining that true life comes through death that eliminates the evil inclination. | Cf. Job 14:4 — The author uses this verse to support his paradoxical claim that death, though associated with impurity, becomes a source of purification by eliminating the evil inclination. | Cf. Numbers 19:14 — The author suggests this verse would have been the meaning of death had Adam not sinned—death as a spiritual transition rather than punishment, possibly alluding to the rabbinic interpretation that connects this verse to Torah study.

[iii]This phrase suggests that the tablets would have conferred a kind of immortality or freedom from exile upon Israel, which Moses deliberately prevented by breaking them. This reflects a kabbalistic understanding that physical objects can embody spiritual properties with real-world effects.

כדי שתשפכנה אבני קדש וכפר
אדמתו עמו ואם כן בשבירׄ
115 לוחות סר עוננו וחטאתנו תכופר
וזה שנאמר בשבירת הלוחות
והלוחות מעשה אלהים המה
כי זה טעם שבירתם ולכן משה
הביאם עמו שלכאורה נראה
120 כיון ששמע מהקב״ה לך רד כי
שחת עמך למה ירד עם הלוחות
בידו היה לו להניחם שם ולא
להביאם למטה אז היה יכול
לומר תדון כפנויה עד יכופר
125 עון ישראל.[i] ברם ידע כי זה
היה תקונם בנזבר. עוד היינו
יכולים לומר בזה כי לא חשב
עון ישראל כ״כ גדול ולפחות
היה סובר שאחר שעשו העגל היו
130 מתחרטים מהעון על דרך שאמרו
הרשעים מלאים חרטות ע״כ
הביא הלוחות בחשבו כי תוקף
אורם יבריחו המזיקים ורוחות
הטומאה שהכניסו ישראל ביניהם
135 אך כאשר ראה העגל ומחולות
שהיו שמחים לאיד אז ויחר אף
משה והכבידו הלוחות על ידיו
שהאורות שהיו בהם נסתלקו
אל נרתקן ואז מה שמתחלה
140 היו שניהם על ידו אחת דכתיב
ושני הלוחות בידו בעת שבירתן
כתיב וישלך מידיו שהחזיק
בהם בשתי ידיו כי מתחלה היו
נושאים את נושאיהם[ii] וכשהגיעו
145 לעשרה טפחים התחתונים שהם
רשות הרבים והקליפות[iii] שגירו

Temple was not built in Moses' time so that the holy stones would be scattered and "He will atone for His land and His people." Thus, through the 115R
breaking of the tablets, our iniquity departed and our sin was atoned for. This is alluded to in the description of the breaking of the tablets: "And the tablets were the work of God"—this explains the reason for their breaking. Therefore, Moses brought 120R
them with him, for at first glance it seems puzzling: since he heard from the Holy One, blessed be He, "Go down, for your people have become corrupt," why did he descend with the tablets in his hand? He should have left them there and not brought them 125R
down. Then he could have argued, "Judge them as an unmarried woman until Israel's sin is atoned for."[1] However, he knew that this [breaking] would be their rectification, as mentioned.

We could further suggest that he did not consider 130R
Israel's sin to be so great, and at the very least he thought that after they made the golden calf, they would regret their sin, as they say, "The wicked are full of regrets." Therefore, he brought the tablets, thinking that the power of their light would drive 135R
away the destructive forces and spirits of impurity that Israel had brought among themselves. But when he saw the calf and the dancing, that they were rejoicing in wickedness, "Moses' anger burned," and the tablets became heavy in his hands because the 140R
lights that were in them withdrew into their sheaths. And so what had initially been both [tablets] in one hand, as it is written, "and the two tablets in his hand," at the time of their breaking it says, "and he cast them from his hands," meaning he was holding 145R
them with both hands. For initially, they carried

[1] This uses a legal analogy from Jewish marriage law, suggesting Moses could have argued for leniency in judgment based on Israel's not-yet-fully-consummated relationship with God. The author is exploring alternative paths Moses might have taken.

[i] This uses an analogy from Jewish marriage law: a woman who is betrothed (but not yet fully married) receives different legal treatment than a married woman. The author suggests Moses could have argued for lighter judgment for Israel by claiming they were not yet fully 'married' to God through receiving the tablets.

[ii] This refers to the rabbinic tradition that the tablets miraculously carried those who carried them, meaning they had no physical weight due to their divine nature. When Israel sinned, this miraculous property was lost.

[iii] This combines a halakhic concept (the bottom ten handbreadths constituting public domain in Jewish law) with a kabbalistic concept (this public domain being associated with negative spiritual forces called 'kelipot'). The author creates a correspondence between physical and metaphysical boundaries.

ישראל בהם האור חמק עבר מהם
כי קצר המצע מהשתרע[i] הקדושה
עם הטומאה והכבידו על ידי
משה ועל כרחו הוצרך להניח
אותם ונשברו ע״ד אותיות
פורחות וגוילים נשרפים. אך
לפי דרכנו יאות יותר הדרך
הראשון ששברן לטובת ישראל
וזה אשר שברת ישר כחך
ששברת:[ii] ועל פי הדברים
האלה לא נכנס משה בארץ שלא
יכופר עון ישראל בחרבן כי
לא היו האויבים יכולים לשלוט
במעשי ידיו ולא לעקור ישראל
מהארץ כי רצונו היה לנטעם
שם וזהו תביאמו ותטעמו וגו׳
הנה חרבן בית המקדש בטעם
שבירת הלוחות וכן הגליות
והמיתה היה רב טוב לבית
ישראל: ובטל שהקב״ה עתיד
להחיות את המתים צדיקי ישראל
שהוא מאור שירד מאריך אנפין
בסוד מלכין קדמאי[iii] בדרוש
עולם התהו׳ עולם הנקודות
לגורי האר״י מטל זה יתהוו בני
התחיה אחר שחלק הבשר שהוא
מחלק נחש הקדום שבשר הוא
ש״בר[iv] ישוב לעפרו כי נחש עפר
לחמו יצורף ויתוקן הויה וחבור

their bearers,[1] but when they reached the bottom ten handbreadths, which is the public domain and the realm of the negative forces that Israel had provoked, the light slipped away from them, for "the bed is too short to stretch out on"—holiness cannot coexist with impurity. They became heavy in Moses' hands, and he was forced to put them down, and they broke in the manner of "flying letters and burning parchments." But according to our approach, the first explanation is more fitting—that he broke them for Israel's benefit. This is [the meaning of] "which you broke"—it was right that you broke them.

Based on these matters, Moses did not enter the land so that Israel's sin would not be atoned for through the destruction[2] [of the Temple], for enemies would not have been able to control his handiwork nor uproot Israel from the land, as his desire was to plant them there. This is [the meaning of] "You will bring them and plant them..." Thus, the destruction of the Temple served the same purpose as the breaking of the tablets, and likewise the exiles and death were for the great good of the House of Israel.

And through the dew with which the Holy One, blessed be He, will revive the dead,[3] the righteous of Israel—which is from the light that descends from Arich Anpin, in the mystery of the Primordial Kings, in the discourse on the World of Chaos and the World of Points according to the disciples of the ARI—through this dew the resurrected ones will come into

[1] This refers to the rabbinic tradition that the tablets were miraculously weightless and even helped carry those who carried them. The loss of this miraculous property symbolizes the withdrawal of divine presence following Israel's sin.

[2] This presents a striking kabbalistic interpretation of Moses not entering the Promised Land—not as punishment, but as divine strategy. The author suggests that Moses' presence would have made the Temple indestructible, preventing the necessary atonement that would later come through destruction and exile.

[3] This refers to the rabbinic concept that resurrection will occur through a special divine dew. The author integrates this traditional concept with Lurianic kabbalistic terminology about cosmic restoration.

[i] A reference to Isaiah 28:20, "For the bed is too short to stretch out on." This biblical phrase is applied metaphorically to suggest the incompatibility of divine holiness and impurity coexisting in the same space.

[ii] This refers to the rabbinic interpretation of God's words to Moses in Exodus 34:1. According to tradition, God told Moses "well done" (yasher koach) for breaking the tablets, confirming it was the right action.

[iii] This refers to complex Lurianic kabbalistic concepts about primordial divine light that existed before creation. The 'Primordial Kings' represent sefirot (divine emanations) of the World of Chaos that shattered because they could not contain the divine light—a process that will be rectified in the resurrection.

[iv] The author engages in wordplay, breaking apart the Hebrew word for flesh (basar) to interpret it as 'broken thing' (sh-bar), associating meat consumption with brokenness and the primordial fall.

ד׳ יסודות זכים וקיימים: ומזה נדע מנהג הוותיקים הפורשים מאכילת בשר ימי השבוע שהוא שליטת החול ועיין מזה בר״מ פרשת לך לך דף פ״ט ע״ב. וכתב הברבנילו שהבשר מוליד באדם דם זדוני ואכזרי. ומפני זה תמצא שהחיות והעופות הטורפות האוכלות הבשר הם אכזריות ורעות אבל אותן המתפרנסות מעשב השדה אין בהם אכזריות ולא רשע.[i] ולכן יעד הנביא שבזמן הגאולה העתידה אריה כבקר יאכל תבן וביאר הסיבה באומרו לא ירעו ולא ישחיתו וכן בעל העקדה בשער מ״א אמר כי אכילת הבעלי חיים הם זבחי ריב וקנטור לאיש השלם כמו שאמר החכם טוב פת חריבה וגו׳ ואולי נאמר שלכן לאדם הראשון השלם בבריאתו לא הותר לו אכילת בעלי חיים. וכן אמרו חכמינו ז״ל על פסוק אשר יצוד ציד חיה או עוף. מכאן שלא יאכל אדם בשר אלא בהזמנה זאת. ודור דיעה שמקור נשמתם היה מהבינה לא הותר להם רק אכילת בשר שלמים ואכילת הכהנים מבשר קדשי קדשים ואכילת הבעלים השלמים היה תקון לאכילת בשר תאוה בזמן שבהמ״ק קיים ועתה יהיה אכילת שבתות וי״ט וסעודות מצוה תקון לזה שגם בשפלנו זכר לנו למען חסדו הגדול. ובשר הוא מצד מדת הדין ואותיותיו מורות זה.[ii] וכן אמרו בפנים חשוכות

being. After the portion of flesh, which is from the portion of the primordial serpent—for flesh (basar) is a broken thing (sh-bar)—returns to its dust, because "dust is the serpent's food," a new formation will be refined and established, a combination of the four pure and enduring elements.

From this we can understand the practice of the pious ones who abstain from eating meat during the weekdays,[1] which is the domain of the mundane. See more about this in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Lech Lecha, page 89b. Barbanilo wrote that meat produces malicious and cruel blood in a person.[2] Because of this, you will find that the predatory beasts and birds that eat meat are cruel and evil, while those that sustain themselves from the grass of the field have neither cruelty nor wickedness in them. Therefore, the prophet foretold that in the time of the future redemption, "the lion, like the ox, will eat straw," and he explained the reason by saying, "they will not harm nor destroy." Similarly, the author of the Akedah in Gate 41 said that eating animals is a sacrifice of strife and provocation for the perfect person, as the sage said, "Better is a dry crust [with peace, than a house full of feasting with strife]." Perhaps we can say that this is why the first man, who was perfect in his creation, was not permitted to eat animals. Our sages of blessed memory also said regarding the verse "when he hunts game, an animal or a bird"—from here [we learn] that a person should eat meat only with this preparation. The generation of knowledge, whose soul source was from Binah, was permitted only to eat the meat of peace offerings and the priests' eating of the meat of holy of holies. The eating by the owners of peace offerings served as a rectification for the eating of meat of desire during the time when the Temple existed. And now, eating on Sabbaths, festivals, and meals associated with mitzvot serves as a rectification for this, for even in

[1] The author connects ascetic dietary practices (limiting meat consumption to Sabbaths and festivals) with kabbalistic cosmology, suggesting that such restraint aligns one with divine rhythms and helps rectify creation through participating in the distinction between holy and mundane time.

[2] This reflects medieval medical theory in which food was believed to directly influence not just physical health but moral character. The consumption of meat was thought to produce 'hot blood' associated with aggression and cruelty.

[i] The author presents a medieval scientific understanding that an animal's diet affects its temperament and, by extension, affects the temperament of humans who consume that animal. This combines scientific, ethical, and spiritual concerns about meat consumption.

[ii] The author suggests that the very Hebrew letters that form the word 'basar' (flesh/meat) indi-

נתן השלו לישראל ברם המברך
215 על מזונו כראוי וכפי כוונת לבו
ממתק הדין והדם נעשה לו חלב
וזריז דלא עבד איסורא ונשכר
דאכיל בשרא ותבא כמים בקרבו
וכשמן בעצמותיו ויאכל וחדי
220 וכל שכביצה ביצה טובה הימנו
לחיי דברייתא חוץ מבשרא: [i]

our lowliness, He has remembered us for the sake of
His great kindness. Meat comes from the side of the 215R
attribute of judgment, and its letters indicate this.
They also said that the quail was given to Israel with
a dark countenance.[1] However, one who blesses his
food properly and according to the intention of his
heart sweetens the judgment, and the blood becomes 220R
milk for him.[2] One who is diligent and does not com-
mit a transgression is rewarded when he eats meat—
"it enters like water into his innards and like oil into
his bones." He eats and rejoices, and even an egg is
better than meat for the life of creatures, except for 225R
meat itself.[3]

פרק י״ז

התחיה היא שלמות גדול לנפש
ג״כ כי הנשמות וכל שכן הגופות
אינם עתה באותו השלמות שיהיו
אחר התחיה וכמו שמקוים החיים

Chapter 17

Resurrection is also a great perfection for the soul,
for souls, and all the more so bodies, are not now
in the same state of perfection that they will be
after the resurrection.[A] Just as the living await re-

[A] Or: "souls—and certainly bodies—are not now in the same state of perfection they will attain

[1] This refers to the biblical episode where God sent quail to the complaining Israelites in the wilderness (Numbers 11), which led to a plague. The author interprets this as divine displeasure with the Israelites' meat craving.

[2] This metaphorical transformation suggests that proper spiritual intention can transform even potentially problematic foods (meat, associated with blood and judgment) into spiritually beneficial nourishment (milk, associated with nurturing and kindness).

[3] This somewhat paradoxical statement appears to suggest that while eggs are generally healthier than meat for most creatures, for human consumption specifically, properly blessed meat with correct intention can still be spiritually beneficial.

cate its connection to divine judgment. This reflects the kabbalistic practice of finding spiritual significance in the letters and structure of Hebrew words.

[i] Cf. Exodus 32 — The text interprets Moses' breaking of the tablets as a deliberate act of mercy that protected Israel from the consequences of possessing the tablets while in a state of sin. This interpretation transforms what appears to be an act of anger into a spiritually protective measure. | Cf. Genesis 3:22-24 — The author draws a parallel between God preventing Adam from eating from the Tree of Life (which would have granted immortality in a fallen state) and Moses breaking the tablets, suggesting both were acts of mercy preventing a worse spiritual outcome. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:43 — The phrase 'וכפר אדמתו עמו' (He will atone for His land and His people) is used to support the idea that the destruction of the Temple and breaking of the tablets serve an atoning function. | Cf. Deuteronomy 34:1-12 — The author offers a kabbalistic interpretation of why Moses couldn't enter the land, suggesting it was so that his divine handiwork couldn't be destroyed by enemies, which would have prevented the necessary spiritual atonement through exile and destruction. | Cf. Exodus 15:17 — The phrase 'תביאמו ותטעמו' (You will bring them and plant them) is used to demonstrate Moses' desire to permanently establish Israel in the land, which the author suggests would have prevented necessary future spiritual correction through exile. | Cf. Isaiah 11:6-9 — The text uses this prophetic vision to support its ascetic approach to meat consumption, suggesting that dietary restraint reflects messianic ideals where violence and predation are eliminated. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna (Zohar) — The author references this kabbalistic text to support the practice of abstaining from meat on weekdays, suggesting it provides deeper mystical reasons for dietary restraint. | Cf. Proverbs 17:1 — The partial quote 'טוב פת חריבה' (Better is a dry crust) is used to support the spiritual value of simple vegetarian food over meat which is associated with violence and spiritual judgment.

הגאולה לתועלת המשך השלמות לאדם. כן המתים נשמתם מקוה התחיה לתועלת ימשך אליהם מהשלמות שאחר התחיה. ומהות טל תחיית המתים יהיה טל מאיכות הנשמה וזהו בוונות הרעיפו שמים ממעל ושחקים יזלו צדק וגו׳ כי יזלו שחקים ע״י מלאכים הנקראים רוחות טל אחר מלבד הטל ממהות הנשמה והצדק שעשו בעה״ז כנגד הנפש. והטעם כי המיתה אל הגוף יצדק בקצת אל הנשמה שהיא נשמת הגוף המת שהמלכות בה יצדק המיתה ומיתה בנוקבא אחידת ובסטרא דנוקבא איהי.[i] אמנם ממנה ולמעלה הם החיים ומה שיתייחס למעלה חיים לא חיים גשמיים ולא מיתה ממש אלא יקרא היסוד חי והת״ת עץ החיים והבינה ארץ החיים והחכמה מקור החיים והכתר ג״כ. הכל בסוד אותו האור שנקרא חיים שהוא רב שפע. וא״ס מתנוצץ באור ידוע באותם הספיר דבר שאין הנשמות צופות בו עתה כלל מפני שהם בחלק המיתה ומיתתם הוא בסוד דאצטנעו דפי׳ בפ׳ הקודם והצנע זה הוא ג״כ אל הנשמות שהם גנוזות תחת כסא הכבוד שאין שם מקומם העצמי כי מקום הראוי ומיוחד להם הוא היות אותם החיים העליונים נשפעים

demption for the benefit of continued perfection for mankind, so too do the souls of the dead await resurrection for the benefit of the perfection that will extend to them after resurrection. The essence of the dew of resurrection will be dew from the quality of the soul,[1] and this is the meaning of "Let the heavens drop down from above, and let the skies pour down righteousness," etc., for the skies will pour forth through angels called spirits of dew, beyond the dew from the essence of the soul and the righteousness they performed in this world corresponding to the nefesh (vital soul). The reason is that death, which properly applies to the body, applies partially to the soul, which is the soul of the dead body, for in the attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom) death is fitting, as "death adheres to the feminine aspect and is of the feminine side." However, from Malkhut upward are the realms of life, and what is attributed to the higher realms is life—not physical life, nor literal death—rather, Yesod (Foundation) is called "living," Tiferet (Beauty) is "the Tree of Life," Binah (Understanding) is "the Land of the Living," Chokhmah (Wisdom) is "the Source of Life," and Keter (Crown) as well. All of this pertains to the mystery of that light called "life," which is abundant effluence. The Infinite One (Ein Sof) radiates with a specific light in those sapphire [emanations], something that souls cannot perceive at all now because they are in the realm of death, and their death is in the mystery of concealment as explained in the previous chapter.[A] This concealment also applies to souls that are hidden beneath the Throne of Glory, for that is not their essential place. Their proper and designated place is to have those supernal life-forces

after resurrection" — This alternate translation maintains the emphasis on both souls and bodies while using 'certainly' rather than 'all the more so' for a slightly more modern phrasing. It also simplifies the sentence structure slightly.

[A] Or: "because they exist in the domain of death, and their death state is through the mystery of 'concealment' (itztane'u) as we explained in the previous chapter" — This alternate translation preserves the technical kabbalistic term 'itztane'u' (concealment) while also clarifying that this concept was previously explained by the author. The term 'domain' might better capture the spatial metaphor implied in 'chelek' (portion/realm).

[1] The metaphor of 'dew' for resurrection appears in Isaiah 26:19: 'Your dead shall live, their corpses shall rise. O dwellers in the dust, awake and sing for joy! For your dew is a dew of light.' This biblical imagery is given kabbalistic interpretation here.

[i] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar states that 'death adheres to the feminine aspect and is of the feminine side,' reflecting the kabbalistic teaching that death is associated with Malkhut, the feminine divine attribute, while the higher sefirot are associated with life.

אליהם והיינו ט״ל סוד יו״ד
ה״א וא״ו[i] שעתיד הקדוש ברוך
הוא להשפיע בה״א אחרונה
להחיות בו את המתים. ואמרו
בריש האדרא[ii] דעל זה איתער
מרישא דאריך ואחר שה״א
אחרונה תהיה מאותם החיים.
אז היא תשפיע. מהחיות ההוא
לכל אותם הבחינות שאין אותם
החיים נמצאים בהם אשר עתה
על צד ההשאלה יקראו מתים.
ועל סוד ההתפשטות החיים
האלה יאמר מחיה מתים את״ה
כי באשר את״ה תסתלק ותתקשר
בסוד י״הו בינה בן י״ה יה״ו
ושם החכמה שהיא שם מ״ה בסוד
אדם מיד המלכות הנקראת אתה
היא מחיה כל אותם הבחינות
שיצדק בהם המיתה עתה והתחיה
אח״כ ופתיחת מקור זה הוא
מחכמה וכתר וזהו מחיה מתים
ברחמים רבים. הנה כי המיתה
היא הכנה וצורך אל התחיה.
ואפי׳ השינה אמרו בעלי המחקר
שהיא מנוחה אל הנפש. ופירש
החכם קורדואירו זצ״ל[iii] כי
בהיות האדם ישן במטתו הנפש
והרוח והנשמה מקבלים החיות
מהבינה דוגמא למה שעתיד
להיות אחר המות וזהו אמרם
במדרש רבה פרשת ס״ו רוח

flowing to them, which is the mystery of ט״ל (dew, numerically 39),[1] the secret of Yod-Hei-Vav that the Holy One, blessed be He, will in the future pour into the final Hei to revive the dead with it. And they said at the beginning of the Idra that this is aroused from the head of Arich (the Long-Faced One), and after the final Hei becomes part of those life-forces, then it will channel that vitality to all those aspects in which those life-forces are not found, which are now metaphorically called "dead." Concerning the mystery of the expansion of these life-forces, we say "You revive the dead" (אַתָּה מְחַיֶּה מֵתִים), for when אַתָּה (You) ascends and becomes bound in the mystery of י״הו[2]—Binah, son of Yah, YHV—and the name of Chokhmah, which is the name מ״ה (45) in the mystery of Adam, then immediately Malkhut, which is called אַתָּה (You), revives all those aspects to which death now applies and resurrection afterward. The opening of this source is from Chokhmah and Keter, and this is the meaning of "You revive the dead with great mercy." Thus death is a preparation and necessity for resurrection. Even regarding sleep, the philosophers said that it is rest for the soul. And Rabbi Cordovero, of blessed memory, explained that when a person sleeps in their bed, the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah (soul, spirit, and higher soul) receive vitality from Binah, prefiguring what will happen after death.[3] This is what they meant in Midrash Rabbah, Parashah 66: "The spirit ascends and descends; when a person sleeps, the soul ascends and draws down life from above." For sleep is

40R 45R 50R 55R 60R 65R

[1] Hebrew letters have numerical values (gematria). The word for 'dew' (טל) equals 39 (ט=9, ל=30), which matches the numerical value of certain letters of the divine name when spelled out fully. This wordplay creates a mystical connection between dew and divine power.

[2] The passage analyzes the prayer phrase 'You revive the dead' (אַתָּה מְחַיֶּה מֵתִים) by interpreting the word 'You' (אַתָּה) as representing Malkhut (the lowest divine emanation) which ascends through the higher emanations during resurrection, creating a flow of divine vitality down to the dead.

[3] The parallel between sleep and death is fundamental to this passage. Sleep is presented as a miniature version of death, where the soul temporarily leaves the body to ascend to higher realms, much as it will do permanently at death. This creates a natural bridge between everyday experience and afterlife theology.

[i] The Hebrew word for 'dew' (טל) has the numerical value of 39, which the author connects to the letters of the divine name (יו״ד ה״א וא״ו) that total the same value. This kabbalistic wordplay links the concept of resurrection to divine names.

[ii] 'Rosh ha-Idra' refers to the beginning of the Idra Rabba (Great Assembly), a significant section of the Zohar that describes the mystical assembly of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his disciples where profound kabbalistic teachings were revealed.

[iii] This refers to Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), known by the acronym Ramak, who was one of the most influential kabbalists of Safed. His systematic presentation of Kabbalah, particularly in his work 'Pardes Rimmonim,' greatly influenced subsequent kabbalistic thought.

היא עולה ויורדת הנשמה בשעה
שאדם ישן היא עולה ושואבת
לו חיים מלמעלה. כי השינה
היא אחד מס׳ במיתה[i] כי הם
ו׳ מדרגות חצונות והאחרונה
שבהם הוא שינה ויש שינה גדולה
של שבעים שנה שכל אחד משש
מדרגות אלו כלול משבעה ונוכל
ליחס מדרגות אלו בחצונים והם
בקוף בפני אדם[ii] גם בדין החזק
הקדוש לכן שינה קטנה היא
חלק אחרון של מיתה והשינה
גדולה היא השבעה חלקים בלבד
מאותו חלק הששי. ויש שינה
שאינה בכלל המיתה והוא שתין
נשמי בשינת הסוס. וזה כשאינו
בחלק העשירי ממש שבמיתה
אלא ששים חלקים קטנים זה
יורה שאינו שקוע בשינה קרוב
אל המיתה אלא מתרחק ממנה
ולא יכנס בשביעי מחלק המיתה
אלא ובשביעית יצא לחפשי
חנם. ואי אפשר לעמוד ג׳ ימים
בלא שינה כי ביום ראשון חסד
אפשר להתקיים. ושני ת״ת אמנם
בגבורה שלישי ששם חוזק השינה
אי אפשר לעמוד ולכן בחוזק
הקליפה הג׳ בהכרח יוגבר עליו
השינה. וכבר אמרנו כי בעת
השילה הנשמה והרוח והנפש
יעלו למעלה לתת דין וחשבון
ממה שעשה ביום ולא ישאר בגוף
אלא נפש הבהמית שבה הכחות
גשמיות הדוחה והמעכל והזן

one-sixtieth of death, as there are six external levels, the last of which is sleep.[1] There is also a great sleep of seventy years, with each of the six levels containing seven [aspects]. We can compare these levels to external forces, which are like an ape before a human, even in holy strong judgment. Therefore, a small sleep is the final portion of death, and the great sleep consists of just the seven parts of that sixth portion. There is also a sleep that is not included in death, which is sixty breaths like the sleep of a horse. This is when one is not in precisely the tenth part of death, but rather sixty small parts, indicating that one is not sunk in sleep close to death but is distancing from it, not entering the seventh part of death but rather "in the seventh he shall go free without payment." It is impossible to go three days without sleep, for on the first day, which corresponds to Chesed (Loving-kindness), one can endure. And the second day corresponds to Tiferet (Beauty), but on the third day, which corresponds to Gevurah (Strength) where the power of sleep is strongest, it is impossible to endure. Therefore, with the strength of the third kelipah (shell/husk), sleep will necessarily overpower him.[A] We have already said that during sleep, the neshamah, ruach, and nefesh ascend to give an accounting of what one did during the day, and only the animal soul remains in the body, which contains the physical forces of expulsion, digestion, nourishment, and the like.

70R 75R 80R 85R 90R 95R

[A] Or: "due to the power of the third kelipah, sleep will inevitably overcome the person" — This alternate translation avoids the masculine pronoun in favor of the gender-neutral 'person' and uses 'inevitably' for 'behekhrach' (necessarily/inevitably) which may flow better in contemporary English.

[1] The author develops an elaborate system relating sleep to death, suggesting there are six levels or gradations of death-like states, with ordinary sleep being the lowest or least intense form. This allows for a nuanced understanding of consciousness as existing on a spectrum between full wakefulness and death.

[i] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Berakhot 57b) that sleep is one-sixtieth of death. The author expands this concept into an elaborate system relating different levels of sleep to different aspects of death and the divine emanations.

[ii] This Talmudic expression comparing something inferior to 'an ape before a human' is used here to describe how the external forces (negative spiritual entities) that govern sleep are merely imperfect reflections of the holy forces that govern life and death.

וכיוצא.[i]

ולבד יש בו כח להתעורר משנתו
כי כאשר בועטים בחיות המועט
שהוא כסא אל הנפש והרוח
והנשמה יתעורר ויאיר כפתילה
הדולקת שכשאינה מאירה
בועטים בה ודולקת להיותה
כסא אל השלהבת[ii] ותקון גדול
תקן הקב״ה לאדם בשינה ומה
גם אל הזכאי שבה זוכה להכנס
בהיכל המלך כאשר אמרנו
למעלה. הנה השינה מנוחה אל
הנפש כי נפש רוח נשמה מנוחתם
בסוד המלאכים שנהנים מזיו
השכינה והגוף אבן מעמסה בלתי
צריך אל המזון אם לא מפני
הנפש[iii] ודבר זה מובהר בעצמו
שהרי אם יחנטו הגוף המת
בשמן אפרסמון והמירה וכיוצא
מדברים השומרים מהעפוש
לאיתעפש כלל וישמור כחו בו

And furthermore, it possesses the power to awaken
from sleep, for when one stimulates the small vitality 100R
that serves as a throne for the soul (nefesh), spirit
(ruach), and higher soul (neshamah),[1] it awakens
and illuminates like a burning wick[2] that, when it
dims, can be prodded to light again because it serves
as a throne for the flame. The Holy One, blessed 105R
be He, established this great remedy for mankind
through sleep, especially for the righteous who,
through sleep, merit entry into the palace of the
King, as we explained above. Thus, sleep is rest for
the soul, for the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah find 110R
their repose in the mystery of the angels[3] who enjoy
the radiance of the Divine Presence, while the body
is a burdensome stone with no need for nourishment
except for the sake of the soul. This matter is
self-evident, for if a dead body were to be embalmed 115R
with balsam oil, myrrh, and similar substances that
prevent decay, it would not decompose at all and
would retain its strength, yet a living person, even

[1] The Hebrew terms ‘nefesh,’ ‘ruach,’ and ‘neshamah’ represent the three primary levels of the soul in Jewish mysticism, arranged hierarchically from the most physical (nefesh) to the most spiritual (neshamah).

[2] The analogy of a dimming wick being prodded back to life illustrates the kabbalistic understanding of consciousness as a form of divine light that can be rekindled through physical stimulation.

[3] The phrase ‘in the mystery of the angels’ (בסוד המלאכים) suggests that during sleep, the soul participates in angelic existence, temporarily returning to its spiritual source.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The passage draws heavily on Zoharic cosmology regarding the structure of the soul, the concept of death as concealment, and the relationship between the divine emanations (sefirot) and the human soul. The discussion of death adhering to the feminine aspect (Malkhut) and the soul’s journey during sleep is particularly Zoharic in nature. | Cf. Isaiah 45:8 — This biblical verse is repurposed to describe the mechanism of resurrection, with the ‘righteousness’ that rains down being interpreted as the divine life-force that will resurrect the dead. | Cf. Shemoneh Esreh (Amidah prayer) — The text analyzes the phrase ‘You revive the dead’ (אַתָּה מְחַיֵּה מֵתִים) from the second blessing of the Amidah, offering a kabbalistic interpretation of how the divine name embedded in this phrase (אַתָּה/You) operates in the resurrection process. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 57b — The text expands upon the Talmudic statement that sleep is one-sixtieth of death, developing an elaborate kabbalistic framework that connects this proportion to the structure of the sefirot and the levels of the soul. | Cf. Moses Cordovero’s works — The author cites Rabbi Moses Cordovero (Ramak) regarding the soul’s activities during sleep, showing how the author builds upon earlier kabbalistic interpretations to develop his understanding of sleep as a prefiguration of death and resurrection. | Cf. Exodus 21:2 — The text applies this verse about Hebrew servants being freed in the seventh year to its mystical discussion of sleep and death, suggesting that the soul is liberated from certain spiritual constraints in the seventh aspect of sleep.

[ii] The metaphor of the wick as a ‘throne’ for the flame parallels kabbalistic concepts of the physical body serving as a vessel or throne for the divine soul, reflecting the hierarchical relationship between the material and spiritual realms.

[iii] This passage presents an unusual view that food primarily nourishes the soul rather than the body, contradicting the apparent physical reality that bodies need sustenance. The author uses the example of embalmed corpses to argue that the body itself doesn’t inherently need nourishment—it is only the presence of the soul that creates this need.

והחי גם אם יחנטו אותו לא יעמוד מפני זה ימים רבים בלא אכילה וטעם זה לפי שהאכילה מזון הנפש לא מזון הגוף כאשר יתבאר בפרק הבא בע״ה: [i]

if similarly treated, would not survive many days without eating. The reason for this is that eating nourishes the soul, not the body, as will be explained in the next chapter, God willing.

פרק י״ח

Chapter 18

הנה אחר שהקב״ה גרש הנפש הזאת ממקום גבוה לעמוד בגוף הזה אינה יכולה ליהנות ממאכלה שהוא השפע עליון. ובצמחים ודברים התחתונים הרי הוא נהנה בקצת מזיו השכינה הכמוס בתוכם וזהו צדיק אוכל לשובע נפשו [ii] והמצוה הראשונה שנצטווה אדם הראשון הוא אכול תאכל. ובזה נבין טעם ענג שבתות וימים טובים באכילה כי הוא תקון ומזון גם לנפש יתירה שכמו שנהנית מענג עליון כך נהנית מענג תחתון שכל מאורעי הגוף הנפש מרגשת ולכן היה הלל אומר לגמול חסד עם העניה הזאת [iii] וכתיב יודע צדיק נפש בהמתו [iv] ומפני דבקות הנפש עם הנפש עליונה ועם הרוח ועם הנשמה מגיע מענג הגוף ענג לנשמה יתירה ובזה מעוררים לה הענג מלמעלה ממש ולזה צריך

After the Holy One, blessed be He, exiled this soul from its lofty place[1] to dwell in this body, it cannot enjoy its true nourishment, which is divine influx. However, through plants and earthly things, the soul does derive some pleasure from the divine radiance hidden within them.[2] This is the meaning of "the righteous eats to satisfy his soul," and the first commandment given to Adam was "you shall surely eat." This helps us understand the purpose of delighting in Sabbaths and festivals through food, for it serves as both nourishment and rectification for the additional soul.[3] Just as this additional soul enjoys supernal delight, it also derives pleasure from earthly delights, since the soul senses all bodily experiences. This is why Hillel would say, "Let me perform kindness for this poor one," and Scripture states, "A righteous person knows the soul of his animal." Because of the soul's connection to the higher soul, the spirit, and the divine soul, physical pleasure elevates to become spiritual delight for the additional soul, thereby evoking genuine delight from above. Therefore, one should focus during every

[1] The Hebrew term 'גרש' (expel/exile) evokes the biblical expulsion from Eden, suggesting that the soul's descent into the body is a form of spiritual exile.

[2] The concept of divine sparks concealed in physical matter is central to Lurianic Kabbalah, suggesting that all creation contains fragments of divinity that can be 'liberated' through proper spiritual intention.

[3] In Jewish mystical tradition, the 'neshamah yeteirah' (additional soul) is believed to enter a person on the Sabbath and depart at its conclusion, providing enhanced spiritual perception and pleasure.

[i] Cf. Zohar III:130b — The text reflects the Zoharic concept that during sleep, the soul partially departs from the body to receive spiritual sustenance, just as mentioned here where the soul enters the 'palace of the King' | Cf. Genesis 28:12 — The text alludes to the biblical imagery of ascent to heavenly realms, suggesting that sleep, like Jacob's dream, provides access to divine realms

[ii] A reference to Proverbs 13:25, which the author interprets mystically to suggest that the righteous person derives spiritual nourishment from physical food by accessing the divine spark hidden within it.

[iii] A reference to a saying attributed to Hillel, who would refer to his body as "this poor one" when attending to his physical needs. This illustrates the kabbalistic view that the soul is exiled in the body and requires compassionate care.

[iv] A quotation from Proverbs 12:10, which literally refers to a righteous person caring for his animal, but is interpreted here kabbalistically to mean understanding and properly attending to one's own animal soul or physical nature.

לכוין בכל ענג שבת ואכילת מצה אל סוד ענג ממש[i] שמשם כל מתיקות מצד הדין והבינה הנמתקת[ii] וכל מיני שמנונית מצד החכמה ולזה אמר אכלו משמנים ושתו ממתקים. ויקנה צרכי שבת ביום ששי ולא ביום חמישי ובכל מה שיקנה יאמר לכבוד שבת[iii] ואמרו כי הזיעה שאדם מזיע בצרכי שבת בה הקב״ה מוחק כל עונותיו כמו הדמעות: וראוי לענג השבת בכל מיני בשמים כפי מסת ידו שהבשמים יש להם רמז למעלה עד הכתר ורומזים בכל הספירות והקטורת יוכיח והלחם רומז למלכות מיוחדת עם ת״ת שהוא לחם. ויין רמזו בבינה ששם סוד יין המשומר ותבשיל במלכות שבה סוד התבשיל עם המציאות התחתון שהם ציקי קדירה סוד בשכמל״ו[iv] ומהתחתונים נעשה למעלה תבשילין ומטעמים כאשר אהב ומיני פירות הם מהת״ת שהם פירות האילן. ופירות האדמה הם ממלכות וכל אלו הם תקוני הענג וכל שתיית יין של מצוה הוא משקה

Sabbath pleasure[1] and while eating matzah on the mystery of true delight,[2] the source of all sweetness from the aspect of judgment and sweetened understanding,[3] and all types of richness from the aspect of wisdom. This is why Scripture says, "Eat rich foods and drink sweet drinks." 25R

One should purchase Sabbath necessities on Friday, not Thursday, and for everything purchased, one should say "in honor of the Sabbath." They say that the sweat a person produces while preparing for the Sabbath erases all his sins, like tears do. It is proper to enhance the Sabbath with all types of spices according to one's means, for spices allude to the highest realms, up to Keter, and symbolize all the sefirot, as the incense offering demonstrates. Bread symbolizes Malkhut unified with Tiferet,[4] which is bread. Wine alludes to Binah, where the mystery of preserved wine[5] resides, and cooked dishes relate to Malkhut, which contains the secret of cooking combined with lower reality—the residue of the pot symbolizing "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever." From these earthly elements, dishes and delicacies that He loves are prepared above. Fruits correspond to Tiferet, as they are fruits of the tree, while earth-grown produce corresponds to Malkhut. All these constitute the elements of delight, and every ritual drinking of wine irrigates the supernal channels with gladdening wine, 30R 35R 40R 45R 50R

[1] The Hebrew 'לכוין' (to focus/direct intention) refers to the kabbalistic practice of kavvanah—conscious, directed intention that transforms physical actions into spiritual catalysts.

[2] The term 'סוד' (mystery/secret) in kabbalistic texts often indicates an esoteric interpretation, suggesting that 'delight' has hidden mystical dimensions beyond its simple meaning.

[3] The Hebrew 'הנמתקת' (sweetened) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the transformation of divine judgment into mercy through mystical unifications.

[4] This unification represents the mystical marriage of masculine and feminine divine attributes, a central concept in Kabbalah that brings harmony to all worlds and enables divine flow to reach creation.

[5] The 'wine preserved in its grapes since creation' is a Talmudic concept (Berakhot 34b) referring to special delights reserved for the righteous in the World to Come, reinterpreted in Kabbalah as divine wisdom stored in Binah.

[i] The word 'ענג' (delight) is significant in kabbalistic thought, particularly regarding Sabbath observance. It forms an acronym for 'Eden Nahar Gan' (Eden, River, Garden), representing the highest spiritual realms and pleasures.

[ii] Refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening the judgments,' where the divine attribute of judgment (Din) is tempered through its union with Understanding (Binah), transforming severity into mercy.

[iii] This phrase should be pronounced when purchasing Sabbath necessities to elevate the mundane act of shopping into a sacred preparation for the Sabbath.

[iv] A complex mystical analogy comparing the residue left in cooking pots to the phrase 'Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever' (Baruch Shem Kevod Malchuto L'olam Va'ed), which is recited quietly during the Shema prayer as it mediates between higher and lower realms.

הצינורות עליונים מין המשמח כמו שהוא משקה אבריו ועורקיו ולזה תהיה כוונתו. הנה כי האכילה היא מזון הנפש בסוד הרוחניות שבהם. ובסוד הברכות שמברכים ובפרט לפניהם וגם לאחריהם מוסיף אור לדבר הנאכל שכל ברכה היא בסוד אור מקיף שהוא למעלה מאור פנימי ואור החצון[i] שבכל הויה קדושה וזהו אמרם כדי שיתברך המזון במעיו[ii] ואמר הכתוב איזו היא אכילה שיהיה בה שביעת הנפש כשהיא בברכה וזהו ואכלת ושבעת וברכת את ה׳ אלהיך. וישראל במדבר לא נצרכו לגדולי קרקע שיש בשפע ההוא תערובת אל הגשמיות והעוביות והמותר והפרש אלא המן היה כלו מזון הנפש והגוף לא היה נהנה מזה ולכן פחותי הנפש שביניהם אמרו בלחם הקלוקל שהיו רוצים מזון הגוף.[iii] ולכן כדי שיהא אדם נזון גם במאכל עליון כמלאכים נתן לו מנוחת הנפש שהיא השינה שאז הנפש רוח ונשמה עולים ומשיגים בדברים עליונים ונזונים מזיו עליון וחם טועמים טעם מיתה והנפש שבה למנוחתה כענין הפטירה אל האדם שאז הנפש שבה אל מנוחתה ולכן צדיקים

just as it moistens one's limbs and veins—this should be one's intention.

Indeed, eating nourishes the soul through the spiritual essence within food. Through the mystery of blessings recited before and after eating, light is added to the consumed food, for every blessing operates through the mystery of encompassing light,[1] which transcends both inner light and external light present in all holy existence. This is why they said, "So that the food may be blessed within his intestines," and Scripture asks, "What kind of eating satisfies the soul?" When it is accompanied by blessing: "You shall eat and be satisfied, and bless the Lord your God." The Israelites in the wilderness did not need produce grown from the earth, which contains mixtures of physicality, grossness, excess, and waste; rather, the manna was purely soul nourishment,[2] and the body derived no benefit from it. This is why those of lesser spiritual stature among them complained about the "miserable bread," as they desired bodily nourishment.

Therefore, so that a person might also be nourished by heavenly food like the angels,[3] he was given rest for the soul, which is sleep. During sleep, the soul, spirit, and higher soul ascend and apprehend supernal matters, nourished by divine radiance. They taste death, and the soul returns to its resting place, similar to when a person passes away and the soul returns to its rest. This is why superior righteous ones like Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his companions could remain for three

[1] The distinction between different types of divine light (encompassing, inner, and external) is particularly important in Lurianic Kabbalah, describing how divine influence interacts with creation at various levels.

[2] The manna is described in rabbinic literature as completely absorbed by the body without waste, symbolizing its purely spiritual nature. This contrasts with ordinary food, which leaves physical residue.

[3] In Jewish mystical thought, angels are understood to draw sustenance directly from divine radiance rather than physical food, representing a more refined form of nourishment that humans can experience temporarily during sleep or spiritual elevation.

[i] References Lurianic kabbalistic concepts distinguishing between three types of divine light: encompassing light (or makif) which surrounds from outside, inner light (pnimi) which penetrates and fills, and external light (chitzon) which relates to the outer aspects of creation.

[ii] A Talmudic concept (Berakhot 35a) suggesting that the blessing over food transforms it spiritually, affecting how it nourishes both body and soul.

[iii] Refers to the Israelites' complaint about the manna in Numbers 11:6, calling it 'miserable bread' despite its spiritual nature. The author interprets this as a preference for physical over spiritual nourishment.

העליונים כרשב״י וחביריו[i] היו
עומדים שלשה ושבעה ימים
ולילות בלי שינה ובלי אכילה
מפני שהיו נהנים מזיו השכינה
וכן ענין מרע״ה מ׳ יום ואליהו
ג״כ ולכן השינה באדם הוא חלק
מהמיתה ועניינו ממש במיתה
והגוף מת[ii] והנפש שבה למנוחתה
ומבואר בזהר עליית הנשמה
בלילה בין הכחות עליונים וממה
שהארכנו בזה הכל הוא הוראה
גדולה על עניין התחייה אחר
המיתה. ומבקשי ה׳ יבינו כל.[iii]

or seven days and nights without sleep or food, because they were nourished by the radiance of the Divine Presence. Similarly, Moses our teacher did so for forty days, as did Elijah. Thus, human sleep is a portion of death, its nature precisely like death—the body dies while the soul returns to its resting place. The Zohar explains the soul's ascent at night[1] among supernal powers, and all we have elaborated on this subject provides great insight into the resurrection after death. Those who seek the Lord will understand it all.

פרק י״ט

עתה יתבאר למה תקנו שיתאבל
אדם על מתו שבעה ימים וכן
עשה יוסף לאביו ובירו׳ פ״ק
דכתובות והביאו הרמב״ם פ״ק
מהלכות אבל וכן הרמב״ן בתורת
האדם כי משה רבינו תקן ז׳ ימי
אבילות וז׳ ימי המשתה[iv] ואולי
זה יהיה טעם האבלות יען כי

Chapter 19

Now I will explain why they instituted that a person should mourn for his deceased for seven days, as Joseph did for his father. In the Jerusalem Talmud, first chapter of Ketubot—cited by Maimonides in the first chapter of the Laws of Mourning and by Nachmanides in Torat Ha'Adam—it states that Moses our teacher instituted the seven days of mourning and the seven days of wedding festivities. Perhaps

[1]The Zohar (especially I:83a, III:119b) elaborates on the soul's journey during sleep, describing how it gives testimony about the day's deeds and receives new insights that may be remembered as dreams.

[i]Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his companions are frequently mentioned in kabbalistic literature, particularly the Zohar, as exemplars of mystics who achieved transcendent states where physical needs were temporarily suspended during intense spiritual experiences.

[ii]The comparison between sleep and death appears in various rabbinic sources, including the Talmud, which calls sleep 'one-sixtieth of death' (Berakhot 57b). The author deepens this connection by explaining the soul's journey during sleep.

[iii]Cf. Zohar — The author draws on the Zohar's mystical understanding of the soul's journey, presenting sleep as a form of death where the soul temporarily returns to higher realms. | Cf. Proverbs 13:25 — The author interprets this verse mystically to suggest that physical eating has a spiritual dimension where the hidden divine spark in food nourishes the soul. | Cf. Genesis 2:16 — The author frames eating as not merely a physical necessity but a divine commandment with spiritual significance from the very beginning of creation. | Cf. Proverbs 12:10 — The author reinterprets this verse about animal care to suggest that the righteous person understands the needs of his own animal/physical soul and attends to it properly. | Cf. Nehemiah 8:10 — The author uses this verse to establish a connection between physical pleasure in eating and spiritual delight, linking the concepts of richness and sweetness to divine attributes. | Cf. Deuteronomy 8:10 — The author uses this verse to demonstrate that proper eating includes blessing, which spiritually elevates the physical act of consumption. | Cf. Talmudic saying of Hillel — The author cites Hillel's personification of his body/soul as a 'poor one' deserving kindness to illustrate the proper relationship between spiritual consciousness and physical needs. | Cf. Numbers 21:5 — The author uses this biblical episode to contrast those of higher spiritual development who appreciate purely spiritual nourishment with those who crave physical sustenance.

[iv]This refers to the rabbinic tradition that Moses instituted both seven days of mourning and seven days of wedding celebration, establishing a balance between joy and sorrow in Jewish lifecycle observances.

הגוף במיתתו נפסק ממנו השפע
משבע קצוות[i] וקיומם וזהו סוד
ימי שנותינו בהם שבעים שנה[ii] כי
עד שם הוא סדר זמנים ופעמים
מתעלה עד בינה אם הבנים
שהוא גבורה עליונה[iii] דאיהי
רחמי ודינין מתערין מינה
והיא הנותנת חיים לסדר זמנים
שכללם כלולים בתורה הנקראת
חדרי בינה ובדעת העליון
המכריע בין חכמה ובינה וי״א
שהוא שער החמשים חדרים אלו
ימלאון והיא מעוברת מסדר
זמנים אלו. ולכן עבור היותר
גדול שבאדם הוא י״ב חדשים
בסוד ו׳ קצוות נוטים לחסד
ושש לדין הם י״ב בסוד חדשי
השנה שהם י״ב שש קצוות מימין
ושש קצוות משמאל ונקשרים של
ימין בשמאל ושל שמאל בימין
ולכן שש חדשי החורף יוצאים
מסוכות שבו נדונים על המים
והולכים נגד פסח שהוא הימין
ונכללים בו ולכן הם רחמים
יותר מימות הקיץ שבהם דין
המצרים מפני שהם יוצאים

the reason for mourning is[A] because at death, the
body is disconnected from the flow of the seven lower 10R
sefirot[B] and their sustaining power. This is the se-
cret of "the days of our years are seventy years," for
this represents the order of time, though sometimes
one ascends to Binah, "mother of children," which is
the supernal Gevurah, from which both mercy and 15R
judgments emanate. She gives life to the order of
time, which is contained within the Torah, called
"the chambers of Binah,"[C] and in the supernal Da'at
that mediates between Chokhmah and Binah. Some
say this is the fiftieth gate, and these chambers are 20R
filled, and she is pregnant with these orders of time.

Therefore, the maximum gestation period for a
human is twelve months,[1] corresponding to the six
extremities inclining toward Chesed and six toward
judgment, totaling twelve, which corresponds to the 25R
twelve months of the year: six extremities on the
right and six on the left, with those of the right
binding to the left, and those of the left to the
right. Thus, the six winter months emerge from
Sukkot,[2] when we are judged concerning water, 30R
and they progress toward Passover, which is on
the right, and are included within it. This is why
they contain more mercy than the summer months,
which include the judgment of the "distress between

[A] Or: "this would be the mystical rationale for mourning" — This alternate translation emphasizes that the author is providing a kabbalistic interpretation rather than a simple practical explanation, which better reflects the speculative nature of the text's approach ('perhaps' and 'this would be').

[B] Or: "at death, the body is cut off from the divine influx from the seven extremities" — This alternate translation uses 'divine influx' instead of 'flow' to better capture the concept of shefa (divine emanation or abundance) and 'extremities' as a more literal rendering of 'ketzavot'. This might be preferable for readers more familiar with other kabbalistic terminology.

[C] Or: "the inner chambers of Understanding" — This alternate translation makes the text more accessible to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology by translating 'Binah' as 'Understanding' while maintaining the metaphor of inner chambers or rooms of wisdom.

[1] This reflects the rabbinic position that human gestation can extend to 12 months, which differs from the modern medical understanding but was an accepted belief in traditional Jewish texts.

[2] The author presents a kabbalistic interpretation of the Jewish festival calendar, where the flow of divine energy follows a pattern from Sukkot (fall) to Passover (spring) and back, with each festival representing different divine attributes (sefirot).

[i] The 'seven extremities' (sheva ketzavot) refers to the six lower sefirot (Chesed through Yesod) plus Malkhut, which together form the divine channels through which life-sustaining energy flows to humans. In kabbalistic thought, death occurs when this flow is interrupted.

[ii] This quotes Psalm 90:10, connecting the typical human lifespan to the kabbalistic structure of the seven lower sefirot, each corresponding to ten years of life.

[iii] This describes Binah (Understanding) as 'mother of children,' a common kabbalistic term for this sefirah that generates the lower attributes. It is associated with Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) but contains aspects of mercy as well.

מפסח שהוא הימין והולכים נגד
סוכות שהוא השמאל ונכללים
בו וכל זה מתראה בבטן האם
העליונה בינה. על כן האדם החי
שמונים שנה עולה עד הגבורות
עליונות ומושפע מהם וזהו ואם
בגבורות שמונים שנה[i] ומשם
ולמעלה הוא ודאי קרוב למיתה
מן החיים כדאמרי׳ בגיטין אבל
אם הגיע למאה חוזר חלילה על
דרך נעוץ סופן בתחלתן[ii] ועל
זה אמרו כיון דאפלג אפלג
אבל עיקר סדר זמנים למטה
במקומן שמשם משפיעים למטה
הם שבעים ולכן האבילות הוא
שבעת ימים שהוא היקף אחד
קטן נגד ההיקף הגדול מז׳
שביעיות ודי זה במדת פורענות
המעוטה. וג׳ ימים הראשונים
צריך התעוררות רחמים כיון
שגופו קיים ולא נבקע בריסו
להוציא ממנו הרפש וטיט וכחות
הטומאה שנתעבר מהם מקשקשים
ומפעמים אותו כצירים בבטן
המלאה כאשר ידרש לפנינו
בגזרת עירין והוא עיקר חיבוט
הקבר[iii] ומירוק הזוהמא[iv] ע״ד
חביט ולא בריך[v] שהם ו׳ עונות

the straits” (the Three Weeks), because they emerge from Passover, which is on the right, and progress toward Sukkot, which is on the left, and are included within it. All of this appears in the womb of the supernal Mother, Binah. 35R

Therefore, a person who lives eighty years rises to the level of the supernal Gevurot and receives their influence. This is the meaning of “and if by strength, eighty years.” Beyond this age, one is certainly closer to death than to life, as stated in Gittin. 40R

However, if one reaches one hundred, the cycle begins again, based on the principle that “their end is wedged in their beginning.” Hence they said, “once one has gone beyond the midpoint, he has gone beyond.” But the primary order of time below, in their place from which they influence downward, is seventy years. Therefore, the mourning period is seven days, a small cycle corresponding to the large cycle of seven sets of seven,[1] and this is sufficient for the measure of minimal retribution. 45R 50R

During the first three days, an arousal of mercy is needed, since the body is still intact and the abdomen has not split open to expel the mud, filth, and forces of impurity with which it became pregnant.[A] These forces rattle and pulse within it like labor pains[2] in a full womb, as will be explained later by divine decree. This is the essence of the “beating of the grave” and the purification 55R 60R

[A] Or: “forces of ritual impurity that impregnated it” — This alternate translation shifts the agency in the metaphor, suggesting that impurity forces actively impregnated the body rather than the body becoming pregnant with them. This might better capture the original meaning of the Hebrew verb ‘nitaber’ in this context.

[1] The author draws a parallel between the seven days of mourning and the seventy years of human life, viewing both as complete cycles of seven (either days or decades), reflecting the kabbalistic principle that microcosm mirrors macrocosm.

[2] The text employs birth imagery to describe the post-mortem process, suggesting that death and the subsequent physical decay involve a kind of ‘spiritual labor’ that eventually delivers the soul from its material attachments.

[i] Another quote from Psalm 90:10, which the author interprets kabbalistically to mean that those who live to eighty years have spiritually accessed the level of Gevurah (the sefirah of Strength/Judgment).

[ii] This phrase comes from Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), an early kabbalistic text. It refers to the cyclical nature of existence, where endings connect back to beginnings.

[iii] Chibut HaKever (the Beating of the Grave) refers to a post-mortem purification process in Jewish mystical tradition where the soul experiences discomfort as it separates from physical attachments.

[iv] This refers to the purification of spiritual impurity (zohama) that attached to humanity after Adam’s sin. Death and the subsequent processes are seen as means to cleanse this metaphysical contamination.

[v] This Aramaic phrase meaning ‘beat but do not bless’ refers to the ritual of beating willow branches on Hoshanah Rabbah without reciting a blessing. The author draws a parallel to the soul’s purification process after death.

נגד הו׳ שבעות שפגם בהם כי
בראשון עדיין נער הוא מיצר
טוב או כנגד שלשה בתי דינים
עליונים שכנגדם היו בעזרה
שלשה בתי דינין כדתנן במתני׳
ולכן הם ג׳ ימים לקטן ולגדול
ששם הוא. והם ע״ב שעות לג׳
ימים. עוד למרק פגם נפש
רוח ונשמה בבי״ע[i] לכן ג׳
לבכי לעורר עליו הרחמים
בכח הדמעות בנדרש למעלה.
ובירו׳ פרק אלו מגלחין תני
בר קפרא עד ג׳ ימים תקפו
של אבל למה שצורת הפנים
ניכרת ואולי כי בזה ימצאו
המקטרגים מקום לקטרג נגדו
כמאמר הכתוב הכרת פניהם
ענתה בם ואמרו בויקרא רבה
פי״ח ר׳ יהושע דסכנין בשם
ר׳ לוי כל תלתא יומין נפשא
טייסא על גופא[ii] סברא דאיהו
חזרא לה וביון דהיא חמאה
ליה דאשתני זיוהון דאפוהי היא
אזלת לה. ז׳ להספד בהגהוהי
עליו כדאמרו רז״ל שנפשו
פוקדת לגופו ומתאבלת עליו
כל ז׳ דכתיב ויבא אברהם שהיא
הנשמה לספוד לשרה שהיא
הגוף[iii] ולבכותה וחוזרת מביתו
לקברו ואין לה רשות ללכת לפני
השכינה עד ז׳ ימים וההספד
הוא זכרון חסדי המת כ״כ ר״ח
בפירושיו כנראה במועד קטן
מהספד דר׳ פדת וסדר הספד אב

of defilement,[A] in the manner of "beat but do not bless." These correspond to the six time periods, against the six sets of seven in which one has damaged, for at first one is still a youth with a good inclination. Or they correspond to the three supernal courts of judgment, paralleled by the three courts in the Temple courtyard, as taught in the Mishnah. Therefore, there are three days of mourning for both minor and adult, where it applies, comprising seventy-two hours over three days. Additionally, to purify the blemish of Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah in the worlds of Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah, there are three days for weeping, to arouse mercy through the power of tears, as explained above. 65R 70R 75R

In the Jerusalem Talmud, chapter "Eilu Megalchin," Bar Kappara taught that for three days the intensity of mourning corresponds to the recognizable facial features of the deceased. Perhaps this is because during this time accusers can find grounds to prosecute against the deceased, as Scripture states, "The expression of their faces testifies against them." In Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 18, Rabbi Joshua of Sakhnin said in the name of Rabbi Levi: "For three days, the soul hovers over the body, thinking it will return to it.[1] But when it sees that the radiance of the face has changed, it departs." 80R 85R 90R

Seven days are for eulogizing, as our Sages said, for the soul visits the body and mourns it for all seven days, as it is written: "And Abraham came"—which refers to the Neshamah—"to mourn for Sarah"—which refers to the body—"and to weep for her." The soul returns from its home to the 95R

[A] Or: "the primary process of chibut ha-kever (grave-beating) and the scouring away of spiritual contamination" — This alternate translation retains the Hebrew term 'chibut ha-kever' which has specific connotations in Jewish mystical literature that aren't fully captured by the English translation. It also more vividly conveys the intensive purification process with 'scouring away' rather than the more passive 'purification'.

[1] This reflects the Jewish mystical belief that the soul remains near the body for three days after death, gradually accepting the reality of its separation from physical existence.

[i] An acronym for the three lower spiritual worlds in Kabbalah: Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action). The text suggests that the three days of mourning correspond to purification in these three realms.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means 'the soul hovers over the body,' describing the initial stage after death when the soul is still attached to its physical vessel before fully departing.

[iii] This is a kabbalistic interpretation of Genesis 23:2, where Abraham's mourning for Sarah is read allegorically as the soul (neshamah) mourning for the body.

בית דין וכמו שלמעלה בגן עדן
מכריזין מעשיו כאשר הבטיח מי
שהגיד למהרר״י קארו בדוגמא
זו עושים למטה ובזה מעוררים
אורות מעשיו בשמים ובארץ.
ואין להספיד אלא כפי כבודו של
אדם כדאמרי׳ במועד קטן ועיין
מזה בזהר פ׳ ויחי דף רל״ב ע״ב.
וההספד למת הוא תועלת גדול׳
כי ע״י הדמעות יופתחו למת
שערי דמעה העליונים שערים
המסולקים מן הדין כאמרם כל
השערים ננעלו ושערי דמעה
לא ננעלו[i] אמנם צריך שתהיה
כוונת הבכי לתועלת הנפש
ולא לתועלת החומר כדרך
הנשים הקלות ודוד המלך ע״ה
יוכיח שאמר אני הולך אליו.
ובענין אבשלום שהיה חוטא
בכה בני אבשלום עד שהצילו
מז׳ מדורות שבגיהנם[ii] ואף
אם היה צדיק שבצדיקים צריך
להספידו וכ״ש שבזה יתעוררו
הרחמים עליו ועל הדור כלו
ויגרמו שישתלשל ממנו במותו
צדיק כמותו לתועלת העולם
ולתועלת הדור כדכתיב ונר ה׳
טרם יכבה[iii] וכן אמרו יום שמת
פלוני נולד פלוני ועוד כי צדקת
הצדיק תועיל לזרעו אף אם אינם
צדיקים ובלבד שלא יהיו רשעים
גמורים עיין מזה בריקאנ״טי פ׳
וירא. ובזהר פ׳ פקודי דף רמ״ז

grave,[1] but it has no permission to appear before the Divine Presence until seven days have passed. The eulogy is a remembrance of the deceased's acts of kindness, as Rabbeinu Chananel explains in his commentaries, as evident from the account in Moed Katan regarding the eulogy of Rabbi Pedat and the order of eulogy for the head of the court. Just as in the Garden of Eden they proclaim one's deeds,[2] as promised by the one who revealed to Rabbi Joseph Karo, similarly they do below, thereby arousing the lights of one's deeds in heaven and on earth. 100R 105R

One should only eulogize according to the honor appropriate for the person, as stated in Moed Katan, and see also the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, page 232b. The eulogy benefits the deceased greatly, for through the tears, the gates of tears above are opened for the deceased—gates that are removed from judgment, as they said, "All gates are locked, but the gates of tears are not locked." However, the intention of the weeping must be for the benefit of the soul, not for the physical body, as is the manner of frivolous women. King David proves this point, for he said, "I will go to him." Regarding Absalom, who was sinful, David cried, "My son Absalom," until he saved him from the seven chambers of Gehenna.[3] Even if the deceased was the most righteous of the righteous, one must eulogize him, and certainly by doing so, mercy will be aroused for him and for the entire generation. This will cause another righteous person like him to be brought forth at his death for the benefit of the world and the generation, as it is written, "And the lamp of the Lord had not yet gone out," and as they said, "On the day that so-and-so died, so-and-so was 110R 115R 120R 125R

[1] The text describes a Jewish mystical belief that during the seven days of mourning, the soul moves between different states: its new spiritual dwelling, the grave site, and eventually presenting itself before the Divine Presence.

[2] This refers to the mystical belief that when a soul arrives in the Garden of Eden, its earthly deeds are publicly announced, corresponding to the eulogy given below in this world.

[3] This illustrates the Jewish mystical belief in the redemptive power of tears and mourning—that sincere grief expressed by the living can actually alter the deceased's spiritual fate in the afterlife.

[i] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Bava Metzia 59a) that while the gates of prayer may sometimes be closed, the gates of tears are never locked, meaning sincere tears always reach God.

[ii] According to Jewish mystical tradition, Gehenna (the realm of spiritual purification after death) consists of seven chambers or levels, each corresponding to different categories of sins requiring purification.

[iii] This quotes 1 Samuel 3:3, which the author interprets mystically to mean that when one righteous person departs, divine providence ensures that another arises to maintain spiritual light in the world.

130 תמצא כוונת הדמעות הנשפכות
על הצדיקים ועליית הנשמות
בהיכל ראשון מהקדושה. ועיין
בפ׳ ר׳ אליעזר דאורג חיוב
הבכי והספד על אדם כשר
135 ועונש המתעצל בהספדו ובפ׳
אלו מגלחין חכם שמת הכל
קרוביו וכו׳ וכן במס׳ כלה פרק
בן עזאי ובפ״ק דמגילה ובפ״ק
דברכות. ואסיפת הצדיקים בעון
140 בני הדור הוא בסוף פ׳ חלק
ובקמא פ׳ הכונס ובמציעא פ׳
השוכר את הפועלים ובסוטה פ׳
היה נוטל ובבתרא פ׳ המוכר
את הספינה ובפ׳ אלו מגלחין
145 ובפ״ק דברכות. ומצוואת רבי
מי שנטפל בי בחיי ימפל בי
במותי בפי דעת מדרש רבה בפ׳
צו הובא בירו׳ דכלאים ובפ׳
הנושא בגמרא וביפה תואר בפ׳
150 י״א משם ג״כ נראה נחת רוח שיש
למת בהספדו: [i]

born."[1] Additionally, the righteousness of the righteous benefits his descendants, even if they are not righteous, provided they are not completely wicked. See Recanati on Parashat Vayera regarding this. 130R

In the Zohar, Parashat Pekudei, page 247, you will find the significance of tears shed for the righteous and the ascent of souls in the first chamber of holiness. See also the chapter on Rabbi Eliezer the Weaver regarding the obligation to weep and eulogize a worthy person and the punishment for one who neglects his eulogy, and in the chapter "Eilu Megalchin" that when a sage dies, all are considered his relatives, etc., and similarly in Tractate Kallah, chapter Ben Azzai, and in the first chapter of Megillah, and in the first chapter of Berakhot. The gathering of the righteous due to the sin of the generation is discussed at the end of the chapter "Chelek," and in Bava Kamma, chapter "HaKones," and in Bava Metzia, chapter "HaSocher et HaPoalim," and in Sotah, chapter "Hayah Notel," and in Bava Batra, chapter "HaMocher et HaSefinah," and in the chapter "Eilu Megalchin," and in the first chapter of Berakhot. From Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi's testament: "Whoever attended to me in my life should attend to me in my death," according to the Midrash Rabbah in Parashat Tzav, cited in the Jerusalem Talmud of Kilayim and in the chapter "HaNosseh" in the Gemara, and in Yefeh Toar in chapter 11. From there too, it is 135R 140R 145R 150R 155R

[1] This reflects the Talmudic concept that there is cosmic balance in the world, with the sun of one righteous person setting as another rises, ensuring continuity of spiritual leadership across generations.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, 232b — The Zohar passage cited reinforces the author's point about eulogies, explaining how they create cosmic reverberations that assist the deceased's soul in its journey and elevate it in the supernal worlds. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei, 247 — The Zohar explains the mystical function of tears shed during mourning, describing how they create channels between this world and supernal realms, allowing the deceased's soul to ascend through the 'first chamber of holiness.' | Cf. Psalm 90:10 — The author interprets this verse kabbalistically, connecting the seventy-year lifespan to the seven lower sefirot (each representing ten years) and the eighty-year lifespan to accessing the level of Gevurah (spiritual strength/judgment). | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) — The author uses this concept from Sefer Yetzirah to explain why reaching one hundred years represents a return to the beginning of the cycle, illustrating the kabbalistic understanding of life as a circular rather than linear journey. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Ketubot, Chapter 1 — The author cites this as the authoritative source for the seven-day mourning period, showing how this practice has divine origins through Moses and establishing a balance between joy and sorrow in Jewish lifecycle events. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah, Chapter 18 — The author uses this source to explain why the first three days of mourning are particularly intense—because during this time the soul is still closely connected to the body, hoping to return to it, creating a period of spiritual instability and need for mercy. | Cf. 1 Samuel 3:3 — The author interprets this verse metaphorically to suggest that God ensures continuity of spiritual light in the world by causing new righteous souls to be born as others depart, maintaining divine illumination through human vessels.

apparent that the deceased derives satisfaction from his eulogy.

פרק כ׳

Chapter 20

הנה זאת חקרנוה כן היא שכל עסקי החי עם המת צריך כוונה גדולה שדבר זה היאך יתייחס למעלה כתבו רז״ל כי הוא קשה מאוד להיותו רמז לסוד הספירות המתעלמות ומסתלקות לנרתקן למעלה מעלה.[i] וכמה צריך לתקנם להרחיצם מכל חלאת עון להלבישם לבנים לבוני הספירות באור המעשה הטוב להתעלות בסוד אחד לקשרם למעלה ולשאת אותם על הכתף סוד עילוי הספירות אחת אל אחת עד שיתעלו למעלה מהכתף לסוד רישא עילאה סוד ההעלם שאין השגה בו. ובקבורה יכוין לסוד ויקבור אותו בגי ומתרגמינן בתליסר מכילי דרחמי שהן נובעות בכתר בבחינותיו הפונות למטה לרחם אל התחתונים ולכן י״ג מדות שהם בדיקנא יקירא דאריך יקראו תקונים[ii] פי׳ שרשי הנמצאים במפורש אצלנו בקונטרס מיוחד לדרוש הלז ומסוד עלית הכתף יעלה הנקבר אל העדן העליון חכמה

Behold, we have investigated this matter and determined that all interactions between the living and the dead require great intention, for how these matters relate to the supernal realms is, as our Sages of blessed memory wrote, extremely difficult to comprehend, as they allude to the mystery of the divine emanations (sefirot) that conceal themselves and ascend to their sheaths above.[A] How necessary it is to rectify them, to cleanse them from all filth of sin, to clothe them in white garments that build the sefirot through the light of good deeds, to elevate them in a unified mystery, to bind them above, and to bear them upon the shoulder—the secret of elevating the sefirot[1] one to another—until they ascend above the shoulder to the mystery of the Supernal Head, the mystery of concealment that cannot be grasped.[B]

In burial, one should focus on the secret of "and he buried him in the valley,"[2] which we translate as "through the thirteen attributes of mercy" that flow from the Crown (Keter) in its aspects that face downward to show compassion to those below. Therefore, the thirteen attributes that are in the precious beard of Arich Anpin are called "rectifications," meaning the roots of all existence, as we have explained in our special treatise on this teaching. From the secret of the elevation of the shoulder, the buried one ascends to the supernal Eden, the Wisdom within

[A] Or: "to their supernal vessels" — The term 'nartikan' (נרתקן) literally means 'their sheaths' or 'their vessels,' referring to the containers or coverings of the divine light. 'Supernal vessels' might better convey the mystical concept of divine containment vessels in the upper worlds.

[B] Or: "the mystery of the Supreme Head, the mystery of that which is hidden beyond comprehension" — This alternate translation might better convey the ultimate transcendence and incomprehensibility of the highest divine level (Keter) in kabbalistic thought.

[1] The Hebrew uses metaphorical language of physically carrying the sefirot 'on the shoulder,' which represents the process of elevating divine emanations through specific spiritual intentions during burial rituals.

[2] This is a reference to Deuteronomy 34:6 describing Moses' burial, which the text interprets kabbalistically to refer to the thirteen attributes of mercy.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the divine emanations (sefirot) withdraw into their concealed, higher state at the time of death, requiring specific rituals to help them properly realign.

[ii] In Kabbalah, the 'precious beard of Arich Anpin' refers to the thirteen attributes of mercy configured in the highest divine countenance, which are called 'tikkunim' (rectifications) because they represent the primordial channels through which divine compassion flows into creation.

שבכתר וצריך התישבות הדעת
בזה מאד וכמו שכמה פעמים
30 יסתרו המדות ויתעלמו גם
הגוף יסתתר ויתעלם בקבר.
ולזה אחרית הכל המות עד כי
יבולע ויתוקן העולם בכללו.
והצדיק במותו נכנס ליהנות
35 בסוד ארבע מאות כסף[i] והיינו
ד׳ אותיות סתומות עליונות
שסודם נעלם למעלה עד הכתר
ועובר ונמשך למטה אל הסוחר
שהוא יסוד והצדיקים נהנים
40 מאותם ד׳ מאות אורות שהם
מאריך אנפין ע״י גלוים ביסוד
שהוא הסוחר המחזר ומסבב
בעיירות ולזה נתן אברהם ד׳
מאות שקל בסף הגשמיים כדי
45 לזכות לד׳ מאה עלמין דכסופא.
ואחר שבעת ימי ההספד תקנו ל׳
יום לגיהוץ ולתספורת שקודם
שתהיה הנשמה מגוהצת ומסולקת
מכחות חומריות ומכתמיה
50 אפי׳ יהיו מעטים צריך לפחות
שלשים יום. ועוד רמז שלשים
יום יהיו בסוד השלשים שנה
הנאמרים במראה יחזקאל שהם
שלשים מדרגות עשר בעולם
55 העשיה ומשם לעשר שבעולם
היצירה ומשם לעשר שבבריאה
שלשים מעלות אלו צריך שתעלה
הנשמה קודם שתזכה להיות
צרורה בצרור החיים את ה׳

Crown, and this requires deep contemplation. Just as the divine attributes are sometimes concealed, so too the body is hidden and concealed in the grave. 30R
Therefore, death is the end of all things until the world is perfected in its entirety.

The righteous person, at death, enters to enjoy the mystery of "four hundred shekels of silver," referring to the four supernal sealed letters whose secret is 35R
concealed above, reaching to the Crown, and flowing downward to "the merchant," which is Foundation (Yesod). The righteous enjoy those four hundred lights that emanate from Arich Anpin[A] through their revelation in Foundation, which is the merchant who 40R
circulates and traverses the towns. This is why Abraham gave four hundred physical shekels of silver, in order to merit the four hundred worlds of delight.

After the seven days of mourning, they established thirty days for laundering and haircutting,[1] because before the soul becomes cleansed and freed from material forces and stains, even minor ones, at least thirty days are required. There is also an allusion that these thirty days correspond to the "thirty years" mentioned in Ezekiel's vision, which 50R
represent thirty levels: ten in the World of Action (Asiyah), ten in the World of Formation (Yetzirah), and ten in the World of Creation (Beriah). The soul must ascend through these thirty levels before it merits to be bound in the bundle of life[B] with 55R
the Lord God in the World of Emanation (Atzilut). This requires great merit according to its ascent and clothing, as it is said: "The garments of the unlearned are impure for the Pharisees,[2] and the

[A] Or: "four hundred lights that originate in the Long Countenance" — While 'Arich Anpin' is a technical kabbalistic term that is often left untranslated, 'the Long Countenance' is its literal meaning and might help readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology better understand the concept.

[B] Or: "until it merits to be gathered into the bond of eternal life" — The phrase 'tzror hachayyim' (צרור החיים) is traditionally translated as 'bundle of life,' but 'bond of eternal life' might better convey the meaning of eternal connection and preservation of the soul in its divine source.

[1] This refers to the traditional mourning period called shloshim (thirty days), during which mourners refrain from laundering clothes and cutting hair. The text provides mystical reasons for these specific prohibitions.

[2] This is a reference to a Talmudic concept (Chagigah 18b) which the author uses metaphorically to explain how souls must be properly 'clothed' or prepared to ascend through various spiritual levels.

[i] This is a kabbalistic interpretation of Abraham's purchase of the Cave of Machpelah for 400 shekels of silver (Genesis 23:16), suggesting that this physical transaction had a spiritual parallel, creating merit that allows righteous souls to enjoy divine illumination after death.

אלהים באצילות[i] וצריך זכות רב כפי עלייתה והתלבשותה ע״ד בגדי ע״ה מדרם לפרושים ובגדי פרושים וכו׳ ואמרו טבל לקל לא טבל לחמור וטבילת קדשים צריכה כוונה.[ii] משא״כ טבילה לחולין. ועיין מסוד שלשים שנה הנזכר בר״מ פ׳ פנחס ואמרו בתקונים כי ל׳ שנה דיחזקאל הם רמז לשלשה חיות התחתונים שהם נצח הוד יסוד והיו על מטטרו״ן הנקרא נהר כבר שהוא נהר דינור מצד הגבורה. והוא רכב לעמודא דאמצעיתא ואיהו רכב אש וסוסי אש. ולפי זה טעם הל׳ יום יהיה להמתיק בחינות הדינים שבל׳ מעלות אלו כי עד שם מגיע קטרוג החצונים לבר במדורין. והמתקתם בסוד גלויים במלכות שמשם מוצא הדינין[iii] ובה בחינת הימים כנודע. אבל עולה ל״ג רמז שבאבלותו על המת מכוין להמתיק ל׳ בחות אלו במלכות ובזה יומתקו שלשה שרשיהם למעלה במקורן. ובתשלום מחזור קטן של הלבנה משם ולהלאה יחלש הדין על הנפטר. ולמעלה כתבנו טעם אחר בזה. על כן אין להתאבל לגדול שבישראל יותר מל׳ יום, מי לנו גדול ממשה שלא בכו אותו אלא ל׳ יום[iv] ואחרי כן כתיב ויתמו ימי בכי אבל משה. וחכמים

garments of the Pharisees..." And they said: "One who has immersed for a minor impurity has not immersed for a major impurity," and "immersion for sacred things requires intention," unlike immersion for mundane matters.

Examine the secret of the "thirty years" mentioned in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas. In the Tikkunim, they said that the "thirty years" of Ezekiel allude to the three lower living creatures, which are Netzach, Hod, and Yesod, and they were upon Metatron, who is called "the river Chebar," which is the River of Fire from the side of Gevurah. He is the chariot for the central column, and he is a chariot of fire and horses of fire. According to this, the purpose of the thirty days is to sweeten the aspects of judgment[A] in these thirty levels, for up to that point the accusation of external forces reaches into the chambers. Their sweetening occurs through their revelation in Malkhut, which is the source of judgments and contains the aspect of days, as is known.

However, the number thirty-three alludes to the fact that in mourning for the dead, one intends to sweeten these thirty powers in Malkhut, and thereby their three roots above in their source are sweetened. At the completion of the moon's small cycle, from then onward, the judgment upon the departed weakens. Above, we wrote another reason for this. Therefore, one should not mourn even for the greatest in Israel more than thirty days. Who was greater than Moses, for whom they wept only thirty days? Afterward it says, "The days of weeping in mourning for Moses were completed." The Sages thought to mourn for our holy Rabbi for an entire year, until

[A] Or: "to mitigate the manifestations of divine severity" — While 'sweeten the judgments' is the literal translation of the kabbalistic term, 'mitigate the manifestations of divine severity' might better convey the theological concept to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[i] Being 'bound in the bundle of life' is a biblical phrase (from I Samuel 25:29) that has become central to Jewish conceptions of the afterlife, appearing in traditional burial liturgy. Here it specifically refers to the soul reaching the highest spiritual world of Atzilut (Emanation).

[ii] This is a Talmudic principle about ritual immersion, applied metaphorically to the soul's journey: just as someone who has immersed for a minor impurity is not considered purified for a major impurity, and immersion for sacred purposes requires specific intention, so too the soul's elevation through spiritual realms requires proper intention and preparation.

[iii] In Kabbalah, 'sweetening the judgments' refers to the process of tempering divine severity with mercy. This occurs specifically through Malkhut (Kingdom), which is the divine attribute where judgments first take form before manifesting in our world.

[iv] This refers to Deuteronomy 34:8, which states that the Israelites mourned Moses for thirty days. The text uses this as the basis for limiting mourning periods even for the most revered spiritual leaders.

היו סבורים להתאבל על רבינו
הקדוש שנה תמימה עד שמצאו
מקרא זה במשה עוד אמרו שלכל
מזל יש לו ל׳ מעלות ותנועת
השמש תחתיו ושולטנותו הוא
שלשים יום בקרוב וגם בחינת
ל׳ יום הם מחזור ממזל אחד
ולכן ל׳ יום בשנה חשוב שנה.
ואיסור הגיהוץ והתספורת אולי
יהיה על דרך שאמרו בבן על
אביו שחייב לומר על אביו
בעת שמזכירו בשנה ראשונה
הריני כפרת משכבו ופרש״י ז״ל
שמקבל עליו כל מין דין מוכן
לחול על אביו. ואמרו במדרש
הנעלם כי נשמתה דאתחזיא
לקבלא ענשה אזלת לבר בעלמא
ומפקדת ליה לאתריה תריסר
ירחי שתא בבי קברי ובעלמא.
ולכן כל שנים עשר חדש יאמר
הריני כפרת משכבו מלבד עוד.
כי דיני אש ומים בגיהנם הם ו׳
חדשים בכל אחד מהם. נתבאר
בזהר חלק א׳ דף רל״ח ע״ב
ופירש דאמרי זה ואח״כ ווי.
וטעם כי משפט רשעים בגיהנם
י״ב חדש ולא פחות[i] עיין פרשת
פקודי דף רס״ג ע״א ובפ׳ בא
אמר דשולטנותא דסטרא אחרא
אינו רק י״ב חדש ולא יותר כי
די בצוק העתים למרק בסיבוב
י״ב מזלות נגד הפגם שפגם ימיו
בסבובם וכל יום ויום גבה חובו
ממנו במחזור הזה בדין המשפ״ט
ששם תקופת השנ״ה כנודע ולכן
משפטי גיהנם חציים הם מצד
ימין וחציים מצד שמאל באש
ובמים ואח״כ ותוציאנו לרויה.
ושם פ׳ פקודי מתבאר הממונה
לשבר עיני האדם בקבר. והאוחז

they found this verse about Moses.

They also said that each zodiacal sign has thirty levels, and the sun's movement beneath it and its dominion lasts approximately thirty days. Also, the period of thirty days represents a cycle from one zodiacal sign, and therefore thirty days in a year is considered a year. The prohibition of laundering and haircutting may be in line with what they said about a son for his father, that he is obligated to say for his father when mentioning him in the first year, "I am the atonement for his resting place." Rashi of blessed memory explained that he takes upon himself all types of judgment ready to befall his father.

In the Hidden Midrash, they said that the soul that is destined to receive punishment wanders outside in the world and visits its place for twelve months of the year in the cemetery and in the world. Therefore, for all twelve months one should say, "I am the atonement for his resting place," in addition to the fact that the judgments of fire and water in Gehenna each last six months. This is explained in the Zohar, Part 1, page 238b, which states that they say this and afterward "woe." The reason is that the judgment of the wicked in Gehenna lasts twelve months and not less, as examined in Parashat Pekudei, page 263a. In Parashat Bo, it says that the dominion of the Other Side is only twelve months and no more,[1] for it suffices in troubling times to purify through the cycle of the twelve zodiac signs, countering the blemish caused during their cycle, and each day extracts its debt from him in this cycle, in the judgment of justice, where the seasonal cycle of the year is found, as is known. Therefore, the judgments of Gehenna are half from the right side and half from the left side, in fire and water, and afterward "You brought us out to abundance."[2]

In Parashat Pekudei, the appointed one who breaks a person's eyes in the grave is explained, as well as the one who seizes the soul. On page 244, the source of the three drops of gall is explained,

[1] The 'Other Side' (Sitra Achra) refers to forces of impurity or evil in kabbalistic thought. The text states that their power over a soul is limited to twelve months, explaining the traditional twelve-month mourning period.

[2] This is a phrase from Psalm 66:12, used here to describe the soul's state after completing the purification process in Gehenna.

[i] This is a Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 33b) that the judgment of the wicked in Gehenna lasts twelve months. The text elaborates on this with kabbalistic interpretations about how this period corresponds to the twelve zodiac signs and is divided between judgments of fire and water.

הנשמה ובדף רמ״ד ביאר מוצא
הג׳ טיפי מרה ומזה בדף רס״ז.
135 ווי מאן דנשיק בהאי עלמא
נשיקין דסטרא אחרא עיין שם
ותאחז בשרך פלצות זכאה
חולקיה ממאן דאשתזיב מניה
בהאי עלמא. ובר נש זכאה איהו
140 קרבנא ממש לכפרא:[i] [ii]

and on page 267: "Woe to one who kisses in this world the kisses of the Other Side."[1] See there, and let your flesh shudder. Blessed is the portion of one who is saved from it in this world. The righteous person is truly a sacrifice for atonement. 135R

פרק כ״א

Chapter 21

כשם שהבן חייב בכבוד אביו
בחייו גם במותו יקבל עליו
דינו כיון שהוא יכול להדיחו
מעליו בכח המצות והמעשים
5 טובים[iii] שיעשה כדי לחסום אותו
הדין להיותו בעולם המעשה
דברא כרעא דאבוה[iv] ומוציא

Just as a son is obligated to honor his father during his lifetime,[2] so too after his death he should accept the divine judgment upon himself, since he can avert it through the power of commandments and good deeds that he performs. This serves to block that judgment, for in the world of action, "a son is like the leg of his father,"[3] extracting him from the 5R

[1] This is a kabbalistic metaphor for improper spiritual attachments or pleasures that contaminate the soul, described in vivid terms in the Zohar.

[2] This opening establishes the work's central theme of filial obligation extending beyond death, connecting traditional mourning practices with mystical beliefs about the soul's journey.

[3] I've translated the Aramaic phrase "דברא כרעא דאבוה" which is a talmudic expression emphasizing the spiritual continuity between father and son that persists even after death.

[i] This Aramaic phrase states that 'the righteous person is truly a sacrifice for atonement,' suggesting that the suffering and death of the righteous atones for others, paralleling the sacrificial system of the Temple.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The text cites the Zohar, Parashat Pekudei (pages 263a, 244, and 267) regarding the length of judgment in Gehenna (12 months), the appointed angels who break a person's eyes in the grave, and warnings about spiritual contamination through 'kisses of the Other Side' (improper spiritual attachments). | Cf. Ezekiel's Vision — The text interprets 'thirty years' from Ezekiel's vision as representing thirty spiritual levels through which the soul must ascend after death: ten in Asiyah (World of Action), ten in Yetzirah (World of Formation), and ten in Beriah (World of Creation). | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — The text references Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd, a section of the Zohar) on Parashat Pinchas for deeper understanding of the mystical significance of the 'thirty years' mentioned in Ezekiel, connecting it to the three lower sefirot (Netzach, Hod, and Yesod) and their relationship to Metatron. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The text refers to Tikkunim (Tikkunei Zohar) for an explanation of how the 'thirty years' in Ezekiel symbolize the three lower living creatures (Netzach, Hod, and Yesod) associated with Metatron, who is called 'the river Chebar' (the River of Fire from Gevurah). | Cf. Genesis 23:16 — The text interprets Abraham's payment of 'four hundred shekels of silver' for the Cave of Machpelah as having mystical significance, representing the four supernal sealed letters whose mystery extends from Keter (Crown) down to Yesod (Foundation), allowing Abraham to merit 'four hundred worlds of delight.' | Cf. Deuteronomy 34:8 — The text cites the biblical account of the Israelites mourning Moses for thirty days as proof that even for the greatest spiritual leader, mourning should not exceed thirty days, which became the basis for halakhic practice. | Cf. Midrash HaNe'elam — The text quotes the Hidden Midrash (Midrash HaNe'elam, a section of the Zohar) regarding how the soul of one destined for punishment wanders and visits its burial place for twelve months, explaining the custom of saying 'I am the atonement for his resting place' during the first year after death.

[iii] The text establishes that the actions of a child after a parent's death can directly affect the parent's judgment in the afterlife, a concept found in various rabbinic sources including the Talmud (Sanhedrin 104a).

[iv] This Aramaic phrase meaning "a son is the leg of his father" is from the Talmud (Eruvin 70b), suggesting an organic connection where the son is an extension of the father, even after death.

מסד רגליו ומוליכו על כנפי רוח ומדלה יבצעהו כדחזינן מאבוה דההוא ינוקא אשר יבא בפ׳ הבא אי״ה. ואולי יהיה דומה תקון זה למה שאומרים בסוף הודוי ואתה צדיק על כל הבא עלינו כי ג׳ שותפים יש באדם[i] והשוה הכתוב כבוד אב ואם לכבודו כ״י כדוגמא זו מי שמת לו מת אחד שחייב להתאבל עליו מחמת קורבת נפשו עם נפש הנפטר ובו עצם מעצמיה וחלק מחלקיה לכן אמרו כי יראה עצמו כאלו חרב וכו׳. חייב להגדיל שערו[ii] שהם כחות הדין ע״ד מוטב שיכנס החץ בי.[iii] יען כי בידו להרחיק ממנו המזיק במעשיו וישם מגן לו להצילו מרעתו בעוף שהיא התורה[iv] המגביה ומסלק כל בני רשף. וכמו שאותה הנשמה הנפטרת אינה לובשת מחלצות לעולם עד אחר הל׳ יום[v] להתראות לפני קדושי עליון ולהסתופף בצילם כמו כן קרובו אשר כנפשו לא ילבש בגד מגוהץ על בשרו וגם לא יציע תחתיו כי עדיין אין למתו לבוש לשכון בתוך מנוחתו תחתיו ובמקומו על כן ראוי ומחוייב בכל הל׳ יום לבקש עליו רחמים יום וליל לא ישבות בכל עונה

foundation of his feet, carrying him on the wings of the wind, and lifting him up,[1] as we will see from the father of that child who will be mentioned in the following chapter, God willing. Perhaps this rectification is similar to what we say at the end of confession: "You are righteous concerning all that has come upon us," for there are three partners in the creation of a human being, and Scripture equates honoring father and mother with honoring God. 10R 15R

Similarly, one who has lost a relative whom he is obligated to mourn because of the closeness of his soul to the soul of the deceased—containing "bone of his bones and portion of his portions"—therefore they said that he should see himself as if he were destroyed, etc. He is obligated to let his hair grow long, which represents the forces of judgment,[2] in line with the principle "better that the arrow enter me." For it is in his power to distance the harmful forces through his actions, and he can create a shield to save himself from their evil through "flying," which is Torah study that elevates and removes all the "sparks of flame."[3] 20R 25R

Just as the departed soul does not wear fine garments in the afterworld[4] until after thirty days, when it may appear before the holy ones on high and shelter in their shadow, likewise the relative who is like his own soul should not wear pressed clothing on his body, nor should he place such underneath him. For his deceased still has no garment to dwell within his resting place below him and in his place. Therefore, it is appropriate and obligatory throughout the 30R 35R

[1] The Hebrew "ומדלה יבצעהו" has complex imagery that's difficult to capture precisely in English. It suggests the son's actions can elevate the father's soul to higher spiritual realms.

[2] The term "כחות הדין" refers to the kabbalistic concept of divine judgment (din) that affects the soul after death, which the mourning practices are meant to mitigate.

[3] "בני רשף" is a biblical phrase from Job 5:7 that's used metaphorically here to represent harmful spiritual forces that Torah study can neutralize.

[4] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that souls must undergo a period of purification before receiving their spiritual "garments" (מחלצות) in the afterlife.

[i] Reference to the Talmudic teaching (Kiddushin 30b) that there are three partners in the creation of a person: the father, the mother, and God.

[ii] This refers to the mourning practice of not cutting one's hair, which the author interprets kabbalistically as allowing the forces of judgment to affect the mourner rather than the deceased.

[iii] This expression suggests that the mourner is willing to take upon himself some of the judgment that might otherwise affect the deceased, through his mourning practices.

[iv] The author uses the metaphor of "flying" to represent Torah study, which elevates the soul above harmful spiritual forces. This connects to the biblical verse "as birds flying, so will the Lord of hosts defend Jerusalem" (Isaiah 31:5).

[v] The author presents a kabbalistic belief that the soul cannot wear its spiritual garments until 30 days after death, which parallels the mourning restriction against wearing freshly pressed clothes.

להזכירו לטוב לפני שוכן מעונה
ולעשות לו ג״כ זכרון נשמות
לפחות בכל שבת[i] כאשר יבא
טעם לזה. וכן נהגו בני ספרד
בהשכבת מתיהם[ii] וכבר נתנו
טעם לשבח למנהג זה, הפוסקים.
וטוב להרגיל לפחות פעם אחד
בכל יום מהל׳ ובפרט אם הנפטר
היה ת״ח והיה לו בית מיוחד
לעסוק בו בתורה. וכ״ש אם היה
מחזיק ישיבה. בניו ובני ביתו או
החזן אם אינון לאו בר הכי ודאי
כי יעשו לו נחת רוח ורווחא
לנשמתיה להשכיבו שם בכל
הל׳ יום ואם יהיה בסוד ישרים
ועדה מה טוב ונעים. ואמרו בפ׳
ויקהל דף ר״ט לית נשמתא דלא
תקבל עונשא תלתין יומין[iii] עד
לא תיעול לגינתא וכן ישכיבוהו
בסוף החדש והשנה. והפסוקים
עם המזמורים מיוחדים שיבואו
בסדרנו הנה הנם ראויים והגונים
לבקש רחמים על האדם גם אחר
פטירתו והחכמים יוסיפו עליהם
מדעתם: שבנו וראינו שהרבה
מעשים אשר היו נעשים בטהרת
טמא מת היו מסוגלים להחליש
כח החצונים כמו שפי׳. הנה
בהזאת אפר הפרה[iv] ובשריפתה
היה מבריח אותם אשר מחוץ
למחנה מושבם. לכן שחיטתה
ושריפתה היתה שם פוק חזי
בפ׳ חקת דף קפ״א. ומזה

thirty days to seek mercy for him day and night, not
ceasing at any time to mention him favorably before 40R
the Dweller on High, and also to perform memorial
services for his soul[1] at least every Sabbath, as the
reason for this will be explained. This is the cus-
tom of Sephardic Jews in their memorial services[2] for
their dead, and the legal authorities have already 45R
given praiseworthy reasons for this custom.

It is good to make a habit of doing this at least
once each day of the thirty, especially if the deceased
was a Torah scholar and had a special house for
Torah study. All the more so if he maintained a 50R
yeshiva. His sons and household members, or the
cantor if they are not capable, will certainly bring
satisfaction to his spirit and relief to his soul by per-
forming the memorial service there throughout the
thirty days, and if it is done in the company of the 55R
upright and the congregation, how good and pleasant
it is.

They said in Parashat Vayakhel, page 209,
“There is no soul that does not receive punishment
for thirty days before entering the garden.”[3] There- 60R
fore, they should hold memorial services at the end
of the month and the year. The verses and special
psalms that will appear in our arrangement are
appropriate and fitting to seek mercy for a person
even after his death, and the wise will add to them 65R
according to their understanding.

We have reflected and observed that many ac-
tions performed in the purification of one defiled by
contact with the dead were effective in weakening
the power of external forces,[4] as explained. Indeed, 70R
the sprinkling of the red heifer’s ashes and its burn-

[1] The term “זכרון נשמות” refers to formal prayers and rituals for the deceased, similar to what’s now called Yizkor or Hashkavah services.
[2] The text specifically references Sephardic practices (“בני ספרד”) regarding memorial services, showing awareness of different customs within Judaism.
[3] “גינתא” (the garden) is a reference to Gan Eden or Paradise, the spiritual realm where righteous souls dwell after death according to Jewish tradition.
[4] “כח החצונים” refers to negative spiritual entities in kabbalistic thought that can interfere with the soul’s peaceful transition to the afterlife.

[i] Refers to the custom of reciting memorial prayers (Yizkor/Hashkavah) for the deceased, particularly on Sabbaths when the soul is believed to experience additional elevation.
[ii] Refers to the Sephardic custom of reciting Hashkavah (memorial prayer) rather than the Ashkenazic Yizkor, highlighting the author’s awareness of different Jewish customs.
[iii] This Zoharic teaching that all souls undergo judgment for thirty days before entering the Garden of Eden provides the mystical basis for many thirty-day mourning practices.
[iv] Reference to the ritual of the red heifer (Numbers 19), which was used for purification after contact with the dead. The author interprets this ritual kabbalistically as driving away negative spiritual forces.

יצא לנו טעם לכוונת הרבה
תקונים שמנהג לעשות עם המתים
להשלים חסד של אמת. הצדקה
שנותנים לכופר נפשם[i] מכפרת
עליהם על הדרך שכתב רבינו
ירוחם וספר התניא ומהרר״י
קארו ואחרים. וכן הזכרת
נשמתם ובן יכבד אב גם אחר
מותו[ii] באשר הובא בזהר סוף
פ׳ בחקותי על פסוק בן יכבד
אב וז״ל האי בחייו. בתר דמית
אי תימא הוא פוטר מניה לאו
הכי דאע״ג דמית חייב ביקריה
יתיר דאי ההוא ברא אזיל
בארח תקלה ודאי מבזה לאבוהי
הוא והאי עביד ליה קלנא ואי
ההוא ברא אזיל בארח מישור
ותקין עובדוהי ודאי דא אוקיר
ליה בההוא עלמא גבי קב״ה.
וקב״ה חיים עליה ואותיב ליה
בכורסייא ויקריה ודאי וסיים
כי ר׳ אלעזר אוקיר אבוהי
בהאי עלמא ובההוא עלמא
השתא אסגי שבחא דר״ש בתרין
עלמין בהאי עלמא ובההוא
עלמא יתיר מחייו זכאין אינון
צדיקייא דזכאן לבנין קדישין
לגזעין קדישין עליהו אתקרי כל
רואיהם יכירום כי הם זרע ברך
ה׳. ור׳ אילא העיד לרשב״י
דבמתיבתא דרקיעא אתעטר
אבוהי דההוא ינוקא המובא
בפ׳ שלח דף קע״א ואתעטר
בשבעין עטרין וכתרין בההוא
יומא וסיים ואמר זכאה חולקיה
דמאן דזכי למילף לבריה. עוד
מזה בפ׳ בלק דף קצ״א ע״ב.
ויזהרו מאד לתקן נפש אביהם
להשכים לומר הקדיש ליחד מדת

ing would drive away those forces from outside their dwelling camp. Therefore, its slaughter and burning were performed there—go and see in Parashat Chukat, page 181. From this, we derive a reason for the intention behind many practices customarily performed with the dead to complete the true kindness.[1] The charity given as atonement for their souls provides them with atonement in the manner described by Rabbeinu Yerucham, Sefer HaTanya, Rabbi Joseph Karo, and others.

Similarly, the mention of their souls and "a son honoring his father" even after his death, as brought in the Zohar at the end of Parashat Bechukotai on the verse "A son honors his father." It states: "This refers to during his lifetime. After death, if you were to say he is exempt from this, it is not so. Even though he has died, one is still obligated in his honor, even more so.[2] For if that son walks in the way of sin, he certainly dishonors his father and brings him shame. But if that son walks in the straight path and his deeds are proper, he certainly honors him in that world before the Holy One, blessed be He. And the Holy One has mercy on him and seats him on a throne and truly honors him." It concludes that Rabbi Eleazar honored his father in this world and in the next world, and now the praise of Rabbi Shimon is increased in both worlds—in this world and in the world to come—more than during his lifetime. Fortunate are the righteous who merit holy children and holy lineage, of whom it is said, "All who see them will recognize them, for they are the seed blessed by the Lord."

Rabbi Ila testified to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai that in the heavenly academy, the father of that child mentioned in Parashat Shelach, page 171, was crowned with seventy crowns and diadems on that day, and he concluded by saying, "Fortunate is the portion of one who merits to teach his son." There is more about this in Parashat Balak, page 191b.

[1] "חסד של אמת" (true kindness) is a rabbinic term specifically for kindness shown to the dead, considered the purest form of kindness since it cannot be reciprocated.

[2] The Zoharic passage quoted emphasizes that honoring parents after their death is an even greater obligation than during their lifetime.

[i] Reference to the custom of giving charity as atonement for the deceased, based on the principle that charitable acts performed in memory of the dead provide merit for their souls.

[ii] The author quotes and expands on the biblical verse "A son honors his father" (Malachi 1:6) to include post-mortem honor, using a Zoharic interpretation that extends filial obligations beyond death.

לילה ביום. וטוב שמלבד הקדיש
יתום יתמיד כל אותה שנה לומר
דברים שבקדושה בצבור כגון
הפטרות ומזמורים וכיוצא כי
הכל נותנים נייחא לנשמת אביו
ויש מי שכתב שטוב לומר הקדיש
אפי׳ בשבתות וימים טובים ור״ח
כי אין הטעם להנצל מגיהנם
לבד כי הרי מועיל להעלותו מגן
עדן של מטה ממדרגה למדרגה
ואם כן מועיל אפי׳ בשבת. עוד
אמרו במדרש רבה פרשה ס״ג
כל מי שיש לו בן יגע בתורה
הקב״ה מתמלא עליו רחמים
דכתיב בני אם חכם לבך ישמח
לבי גם אני. וכשאין הבנים
הולכין בדרך ישר מלאכי הדין
מכים וחובטים אביהם שזה ילד
וזה גדל כמו דאמור רבנן כמאן
קרינן לרשיעא בר צדיקא רשיעא
בר רשיעא[i] וכו׳. וברא מזכה
אבא[ii] כמו שאמר המלך החכם
יסר בנך ויניחך ויתן מעדנים
לנפשך:[iii]

They should be very careful to rectify the soul of their father by rising early to recite the Kaddish,[1] which unifies the attribute of night with day.[2] It is good that besides the Orphan's Kaddish, one should persist throughout that year in reciting sacred matters in public, such as haftarot and psalms and the like, for all these provide comfort to the soul of one's father. There are those who write that it is good to recite Kaddish even on Sabbaths, festivals, and New Moons, for the reason is not only to be saved from Gehenna, but it is also effective in elevating the deceased from the lower Garden of Eden[3] from level to level, and if so, it is beneficial even on the Sabbath. 115R 120R

They further said in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 63, "For anyone who has a son who labors in Torah, the Holy One, blessed be He, is filled with compassion toward him, as it is written, 'My son, if your heart is wise, my heart too will be glad' (Proverbs 23:15)." And when sons do not walk in the straight path, the angels of judgment strike and beat their father, for "this one he bore and this one he raised," as the rabbis said, "How do we refer to a wicked son of a righteous man? A wicked son of a wicked man," etc. 125R 130R

[1]The text emphasizes the importance of saying Kaddish (the mourner's prayer) specifically in the morning, connecting it to kabbalistic notions of unifying cosmic forces.

[2]This refers to the kabbalistic concept of unifying the divine feminine (associated with night) and masculine (associated with day) through prayer.

[3]The text presents a multi-leveled conception of Gan Eden (Paradise), where souls can progress to higher levels through their descendants' actions.

[i]This expression "a wicked person, son of a wicked person" comes from the Talmud (Bava Metzia 85a) and suggests that a child's negative behavior reflects poorly on the deceased parent and affects them in the afterlife.

[ii]Aramaic phrase meaning "a son brings merit to his father," expressing the concept that a child's righteous actions can elevate their deceased parent's soul in the afterlife.

[iii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Bechukotai — The author directly quotes this Zoharic passage about a son's obligation to honor his father even after death, using it as a primary textual basis for the entire discussion of post-mortem filial duties. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This Zoharic teaching that all souls undergo judgment for thirty days before entering the Garden of Eden serves as the mystical foundation for the thirty-day mourning customs discussed in the text. | Cf. Talmud, Kiddushin 30b — The text alludes to the Talmudic teaching about the three partners in human creation (father, mother, and God) to explain why honoring parents is equated with honoring God. | Cf. Talmud, Eruvin 70b — The phrase "a son is the leg of his father" is quoted from this Talmudic source to emphasize the organic connection between father and son that persists even after death. | Cf. Proverbs 29:17 — The author quotes this verse to conclude his discussion about the reciprocal relationship between a son's actions and a father's spiritual state, even after death. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah — This midrashic passage is quoted to show that a son's Torah study brings divine mercy upon his father, reinforcing the central theme that children's actions affect parents spiritually. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shelach — The reference to a father being crowned in heaven due to his son's merit elaborates on the spiritual rewards that come to parents whose children follow righteous paths. | Cf. Sefer HaTanya — The author references this work alongside other rabbinic authorities to substantiate the practice of giving charity as atonement for the

"A son brings merit to his father," as said by the wise king, "Discipline your son, and he will give you rest; he will bring delight to your soul" (Proverbs 29:17). 135R

פרק כ״ב

Chapter 22

כל זה תהיה הערה גדולה לכם בני כי תעשו נא אתי ברכה ותשתדלו בכל מאמצי בחכם לזכות אביכם המך והדל הצריך ודאי לרחמים הם רחמי שמים הרבים. אך גם אתם תהיו לאחדים לאושיד מיין נוקבין נגדם[i] כי מנעוריכם גמל עליכם בחסד אל.[ii] שגבר עליו להעמידכם בבית הספר ולקבוע עתים לתורה בכל יום ומנעוריכם ועד היום הזה לא בקשתי מכם לא דבר קטן וגדול בעולם הזה והא ביתא קמייכו ומתכא דרחמנא דגמל עלי תאכלו ותשבעו ואם תרצו לחסות בצילי[iii] שלי ושלכם

Let this be a great reminder to you, my sons,[1] that you should please do me a kindness and strive with all your might to bring merit to your father, who is lowly and poor[B] and certainly in need of mercy—the abundant mercies of Heaven. But you too should be unified in raising feminine waters toward them,[C] for from your youth He has bestowed kindness upon you through God's grace, which empowered me to establish you in school and set fixed times for Torah study each day. From your youth until this day, I have not asked of you anything small or great in this world. Behold, the house is before you, and the table of the Merciful One who has dealt bountifully with me—eat and be satisfied,[D] and if you wish to take shelter in my shade, what is mine is yours. However, one thing I ask of you, this I request: that you keep the way of the Lord.[2] 5R 10R 15R

[B]Or: "who is humble and impoverished" — These terms could refer to either material or spiritual poverty. In this context, the author may be expressing spiritual humility rather than material poverty, though both readings are possible.

[C]Or: "to pour out your receptive spiritual energies in response" — The phrase 'mayin nukvin' (feminine waters) is a technical Kabbalistic term referring to human spiritual arousal that ascends to stimulate divine response. A less technical translation might better serve readers unfamiliar with Kabbalistic terminology.

[D]Or: "Behold, the house stands before you, and from the table that the Compassionate One has provided for me, you shall eat and be satisfied" — This alternate translation clarifies the relationship between the clauses and makes explicit that the father is offering his divinely-given sustenance to his children.

[1]The author is beginning what appears to be an ethical will (tzava'ah), a traditional genre where fathers leave spiritual and practical guidance to their children before death.

[2]This phrase introduces what will likely be a series of religious instructions, framing them not

deceased. | Cf. Rabbi Joseph Karo — The author cites Rabbi Joseph Karo as an authoritative source supporting the practice of giving charity as atonement for the deceased. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Chukat — This reference explains the mystical significance of the red heifer ritual, which the author connects to practices that weaken negative spiritual forces affecting the deceased. | Cf. Numbers 19 — The allusion to the red heifer ritual provides a biblical precedent for purification practices related to death, which the author interprets kabbalistically.

[i]This is a kabbalistic concept referring to 'feminine waters,' representing human spiritual arousal that rises upward to stimulate divine response (the 'masculine waters'). The author uses this mystical terminology to describe how the children should direct their spiritual energies toward heaven, just as their father has directed divine blessings toward them.

[ii]The phrase 'chesed El' refers to divine loving-kindness, one of the primary divine attributes (sefirot) in Kabbalah. The author is attributing his ability to provide for his children to this divine quality rather than to his own merit.

[iii]The metaphor of seeking shelter in one's shade appears in biblical and rabbinic literature, often referring to divine protection. Here it represents both literal protection under the father's roof and the spiritual shelter provided by his Torah teachings.

לכם. ברם אחת אשאל מאתכם
אותה אבקש כי תשמרו דרך ה׳
[i]

לעשות צדקה ומשפט וכל
מעשיכם יהיו לשם שמים כרבי
יהודה בן בבא בירושלמי פ״ב
דסוטה. ואמרו במ״ר פ׳ ראה
הסייף והספר ירדו כרוכים מן
השמים[ii] אם תעשו מה שבתוך
הספר אתם ניצולים מן הסייף
וכו׳: ותעשו עצמכם בכל יום
בבוקר כשכירי יום לאמר היום
הזה אהיה עבד נאמן לאדון
הכל. ושמרו עצמיכם בכל
אותו היום מכעס ושקר ושנאה
ותחרות וקנאה ומלהסתכל
בנשים ותמחלו לכל מי שיצער
אתכם ותבקשו רחמים כמו חצי
שעה בבית הכנסת לה׳ שיעזרכם
על התשובה וכן תעשו למחרתו
ולפחות תקבעו יום אחד בשבוע
לזה. ואם תתענו בו יישר כחכם:
ואל ימוש ספר התורה והמשנה
מפיכם ותהגו בהם יומם ולילה
כפי השגתכ׳. הלא תדעו כי
בהיכל חמישי יש שלשים ושתים
יתידות הממונים על העוסקים
בתורה תמיד.[iii] וסוד היתדו׳
הם מלאכים ואופנים ומדרגו׳
שעלויי׳ ותקונ׳ עולה ממעשה
הארץ הלזו. או לפחות תקבעו
עתים להגות בתורת ה׳ בכל

To practice righteousness and justice, and may all your deeds be for the sake of Heaven, like Rabbi Judah ben Baba in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sotah, chapter 2. And they said in Midrash Rabbah, Parashat Re'eh: "The sword and the book descended from heaven bound together; if you fulfill what is written in the book, you will be saved from the sword, etc." 20R 25R

Make yourselves each morning like day laborers, saying, "Today I will be a faithful servant to the Master of All." Guard yourselves throughout the day from anger, falsehood, hatred, strife, jealousy, and from gazing at women. Forgive anyone who distresses you, and seek mercy for about half an hour in the synagogue, praying to the Lord to help you with repentance. Do likewise the next day, and at the very least, set aside one day each week for this. And if you fast on that day, may your strength increase. 30R 35R

Do not let the book of the Torah and the Mishnah depart from your mouths; meditate on them day and night according to your ability. Do you not know that in the fifth celestial palace there are thirty-two pillars appointed over those who constantly engage in Torah study? The secret of these pillars is that they are angels, celestial wheels, and spiritual levels whose elevation and rectification arise from the deeds performed in this world. At the very least, establish fixed times for studying the Lord's Torah every day and night for the sake of Heaven, to give satisfaction 40R 45R

merely as the father's personal wishes but as divine commandments that the children should observe.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author employs the Kabbalistic concept of 'mayin nukvin' (feminine waters), which represents human spiritual awakening that rises to stimulate divine response ('mayin dekhrin' or masculine waters). This concept appears frequently in the Zohar as part of the cosmic male-female dynamics of divine union. | Cf. Genesis 32:11 — The author's self-description as 'lowly and poor' echoes Jacob's humble statement 'קטנתי מכל החסדים' (I am unworthy of all the kindness), establishing a parallel between the author and the biblical patriarch who also gave instructions to his children. | Cf. Proverbs 3:18 — The metaphor of 'taking shelter in my shade' likely alludes to the protective power of Torah study, which the author has established for his children, drawing on traditional imagery of Torah as a tree providing shelter and protection.

[ii] This is a famous rabbinic metaphor suggesting that divine punishment and divine wisdom are intrinsically connected. The image conveys that Torah observance leads to protection, while its neglect leads to suffering.

[iii] This refers to kabbalistic cosmology where the heavenly realms are organized into palaces (heikhalot). The thirty-two pillars likely correspond to the thirty-two paths of wisdom mentioned in Sefer Yetzirah, an ancient Jewish mystical text.

יום ובכל לילה לש״ש ולעשות
נחת רוח ליוצרכ׳ וליחוד קב״ה
ושכינתיה. וספרו בירושלמי
בפרק ט׳ דסוטה דחד דהוה
קרי ליה לאחוהי בצור והוון
צוחין ליה בפרקמטיא והוא אמר
ליה אנא מבטלא עונתי אין אמי
למיתי מיתי הוא.[i] ויהיה משאכ׳
ומתלכ׳ בשוק נאה. ותזהרו מאד
לישא וליתן באמונה כי האמונה
היא מלבות סוד הקדושה אמונתן
של ישראל.[ii] ויש לאדם לישא
וליתן בה. כדי שיהיה הכל בתוך
הקדש ולא יצא לחוץ אל מקום
השקר והחצונים כי הריוח שיהיה
לכם באמונה הוא שפע הקדושה
ושכנגדו הוא שפע אל זר ח״ו
ובא זה ומאבד את זה. וגרסינן
בסוף מס׳ מכות בא חבקוק
והעמידן על אחת שנאמר וצדיק
באמונתו יחיה. ותנו מממונכם
בעין יפה לצדקה בכל יום וכן
בכל מצוה כי מלח ממון חסר.
וכל מי שיתן למצוה אינו מחסר
נכסיו ולכך נאמר כי נר מצוה.
שאלף אלפים מדליקין ממנו
ואורו במקומו עומד כן הובא
בש״ר פ׳ ל״ו. ואל תונו שום אדם
שכל ממון שאינו של יושר הבא
ליד האדם הוא מהשפעות הבאים
מכח השטן ומצנורותיו הנשברים
הבאים מכח ס״מ ולילית וזה
דומה לעבודה נכריה לכן תחלת
הדין נשאת ונתת באמונה שהיא
עקר האחיזה לבעלי דת הקדש
וצנורות אלו לא יכילו מים חיים.
ומרים הם באחרונה לגוף כי
ודאי זה מאבד את זה ועולה לא
מצלח וגזלן לא עלה בידו אלא
גזלנותו וכלי זיין של השטן הוא
הזהב שיתו לבכם כי ש״ם הזה״ב
בגימטריא שט״ן.[iii] כי לעות אדם

to your Creator, and for the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence. They related in the Jerusalem Talmud, chapter 9 of Sotah, about someone whose brother called him to Tyre for business matters, but he said, "I will not neglect my set time for study; if my mother is destined to die, she will die." 50R

Let your business dealings and conduct in the marketplace be pleasant. Be extremely careful to conduct business honestly, for faith/trustworthiness is the attribute of Malkhut, the secret of holiness, the faith of Israel. A person must conduct business with it so that everything remains within the realm of holiness and does not go outside to the place of falsehood and external forces. For the profit you gain through honesty is the flow of holiness, while its opposite is the flow of a foreign god, Heaven forbid, and one destroys the other. We learn at the end of Tractate Makkot: "Habakkuk came and established them on one principle, as it is said: 'And the righteous shall live by his faith.'" 55R 60R 65R

Give generously from your money for charity every day, and likewise for every commandment, for money needs to be "salted" [i.e., reduced through charity]. Anyone who gives for a commandment does not diminish his possessions, and thus it is said, "For a commandment is a lamp," because thousands upon thousands can light from it while its light remains in place, as brought in Shemot Rabbah, chapter 36. Do not wrong anyone, for any money gained dishonestly that comes into a person's hand derives from influences that come through the power of Satan and his broken channels, which come from the power of Samael and Lilith. This resembles foreign worship. Therefore, the first judgment [in the afterlife] concerns whether one conducted business honestly, for this is the primary connection for those of the holy faith. These broken channels cannot contain living waters and are ultimately bitter for the body, for surely one destroys the other. The evildoer does not prosper, and the robber gains nothing but his own thievery. The weapon of Satan is gold—take note 70R 75R 80R 85R

[i] This striking statement demonstrates the supreme importance placed on Torah study. The individual is saying that even if his mother were to die, he would not neglect his fixed time for study, illustrating the principle that Torah study takes precedence over most other obligations.

[ii] This is a kabbalistic concept identifying faith/trustworthiness (emunah) with the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom), the lowest of the sefirot that acts as a vessel for divine flow into the world. Business dealings conducted with integrity maintain this channel of divine blessing.

[iii] This refers to Hebrew gematria (numerical values of letters): the Hebrew word for gold

בריבו ה׳ לא ראה. ומה שאינו
נגזר לכם בר״ה מב״ד עליון
הצדק לא יוסיף ואם תגרעו חק
חברכם מאשר נגזר עליו בגזול
אותו הקב״ה יטלנו מכם ויחזיר
לו הגזלה אשר נגזל כמו שאמר
יהושפט לדייני ישראל דעו כי
לא לאדם תשפוטו כי לאלהים
כי הוא יחזיר לעשוק את אשר
עשקוהו שלא בדין תורתנו
הקדושה. ובזה יאמר עליכם
ברוך שזה ילד וברוך שזה גדל.
וכל גדול יהיה בכל פינות שאתם
פונים ואפילו בדברי חול וכל
שכן בדברי מצוה לעולם יהיה
לעבוד את השם כי המבין כוונת
וביאור מלות לעבוד את ה׳ הוא
כמו רמז יחוד קב״ה ושכינתיה
שהוא ה׳ הוא אלהים בריך שמיה
לעלם ולעלמי עלמיא. ולעולם
אל דמי לכם מכוונה כוללת
זו. ואמרו על רבי טרפון ע״ה
כשהיה שומע דבר הגון בתורה
היה אומר כפתור ופרח לרמוז
שעל ידי אותו חידוש[i][ii]

that the Hebrew word for "gold" (hazahav) has the same numerical value as "Satan." 90R

"To pervert a man in his cause, the Lord does not see." What has not been decreed for you at Rosh Hashanah by the heavenly court of justice will not be added, and if you diminish what is due to your fellow by robbing him, the Holy One, blessed be He, will 95R take it from you and return the stolen property to the one who was robbed. As Jehoshaphat said to the judges of Israel: "Know that you judge not for man but for God, for He will return to the oppressed what was taken from him unjustly according to our holy 100R Torah." And then it will be said of you, "Blessed is he who bore this child, and blessed is he who raised him."

Let there be greatness in all corners to which you turn, even in mundane matters and certainly in mat- 105R ters of commandments. Always serve the Lord, for one who understands the intention and explanation of the words "to serve the Lord" understands the allusion to the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence, which is "The Lord, 110R He is God, blessed be His name forever and for all eternity." Never cease from this all-encompassing intention. They said of Rabbi Tarfon, of blessed memory, that when he would hear something proper in Torah, he would say "A knob and a flower!" alluding to the fact that through such an innovation, the 115R bride is adorned and united with Tiferet, which is like an apple.

(hazahav—הזהב) has the numerical value 14 (ה = 5, ז = 7, ה = 5, ב = 2), which equals the value of the word Satan (שטן: ש = 3, ט = 9, ן = 2). This numerical equivalence is used to warn against the spiritual dangers of materialism.

[i] This phrase comes from the biblical description of the menorah (Exodus 25:33). In rabbinic literature, it became an expression of praise for an elegant Torah interpretation. Here it's given a kabbalistic interpretation, suggesting that a Torah insight adorns the Shekhinah (the bride) and unites her with Tiferet (the groom).

[ii] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sotah, chapter 2 — This reference establishes the religious foundation for the ethical will—that spiritual intention should underlie all actions | Cf. Midrash Rabbah, Parashat Re'eh — This metaphor emphasizes that Torah study is not merely academic but has real-world consequences for protection and prosperity | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sotah, chapter 9 — This reference serves as a model for the author's children to prioritize spiritual commitments over financial opportunities | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Tractate Makkot 24a — This reinforces the importance of faith/trustworthiness (emunah) as not just a virtue but as the foundational principle for religious life | Cf. Shemot Rabbah, chapter 36 — This analogy is used to encourage charitable giving by assuring that giving to others doesn't reduce one's own prosperity | Cf. 2 Chronicles 19:6 — This reference reinforces the theological principle that justice is ultimately divine, not merely human, and that God will ensure justice is ultimately served | Cf. Song of Songs (implied through kabbalistic interpretation) — This reference uses bridal imagery from Song of Songs within a kabbalistic framework where Torah innovations beautify the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) and unite her with Tiferet (another divine attribute)

קושט הכלה שהיא פרח ומיחדה
עם ת״ת שהוא תפוח. וכן שפיר
קאמרת הא אוקמוה ושפיר ירצה
כבר נתקשטה השכינה בחידוש
ההוא.[i] ואיני מטריח לסגף
עצמכם בתעניות הגם דהשתא
כל בני עלמא בעלי תשובה נינהו
וצריכים סגוף ותקון ויהי מה
אלו לעצתי תשמעון לפחות יום
שני וחמישי שבכל שבוע בימים
שאומרים בהם תחנה מה טוב
לנפשכם וגם יועיל לבריאות
הגוף אם תנהיגו עצמכם לאכול
לחם צר ומים במשורה בסעודת
הבקר ותכוונו לתקון שכינה
ולכפרת נפשכם עם כל ישראל.
להיותם ימי דין ובזה תבסמו
דין הגבורה השולטת ביום
שני.[ii] ולזאת תהיה כוונתכם
בשתיית המים ומדת הוד השולטת
ביום חמישי. שבעוונותינו
נהפכה לדוה[iii] ובזה יתמתק
גבורה עלאה ותתאה ותכוונו
בסוד האכילה כאשר באר בעל
ר״ח בשער הקדושה.[iv] ובזהר
במקומות הרבה. ואחר הסעודות

He adorns the bride who is the blossom and unites her with Tiferet which is the apple.[1] And likewise when you say well, "This has been established," it means the Divine Presence has already been adorned through that innovation. I am not burdening you to mortify yourselves with fasts, even though nowadays all people in the world are penitents and require mortification and rectification.[2] Nevertheless, if you would listen to my advice, at least on Mondays and Thursdays of each week, days when supplications are recited,[3] how good it would be for your souls. It would also benefit your physical health if you train yourselves to eat sparse bread and water in measure for the morning meal, and direct your intention toward rectifying the Divine Presence and atoning for your souls along with all Israel. Since these are days of judgment, in this way you will sweeten the judgment of Gevurah that rules on Monday. This should be your intention while drinking water, and likewise regarding the attribute of Hod which rules on Thursday, which due to our sins has been transformed to illness.[4] Through this practice, the higher and lower Gevurah will be sweetened. You should also focus on the mystical dimension of eating, as explained by the author of Reishit Chochmah in Sha'ar HaKedushah, and in many places in the Zohar. After these meals,

[1] This metaphorical language refers to kabbalistic concepts where Torah insights are seen as adornments for the Shekhinah (Divine Presence, symbolized as the bride), which unite her with Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony, the central divine attribute, symbolized as the apple). The author is describing how proper Torah interpretations have cosmic effects.

[2] This suggests the text was written during or after a period of collective hardship that was interpreted as divine punishment requiring repentance, possibly referencing historical events affecting Jewish communities in Italy during the author's lifetime.

[3] Mondays and Thursdays were traditional fast days in Jewish practice, when additional prayers of supplication (Tachanun) are recited. These days were considered especially propitious for penitential practices.

[4] This contains a wordplay in Hebrew between הוד (Hod/splendor) and דוה (daveh/illness), suggesting that sin has inverted or corrupted the divine attribute. The transformation of divine attributes due to human sin is a common kabbalistic concept.

[i] This is a kabbalistic interpretation of the traditional Talmudic praise for a good interpretation. When one offers a sound Torah insight, it adorns the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), metaphorically referred to as the Bride, and unites her with Tiferet (the central divine attribute, representing masculine divine energy).

[ii] According to kabbalistic tradition, each day of the week corresponds to a different divine attribute (sefirah). Monday is associated with Gevurah (Judgment/Severity), while Thursday is associated with Hod (Splendor/Submission). Fasting or eating sparingly on these days 'sweetens' or mitigates the severity of these divine attributes.

[iii] This contains a wordplay in Hebrew between הוד (Hod/splendor) and דוה (illness/suffering), suggesting that due to Israel's sins, the divine attribute of Hod has been inverted or corrupted into its negative counterpart. This transformation of divine attributes due to human sin is a common kabbalistic concept.

[iv] This refers to Rabbi Eliyahu de Vidas (1518-1592), author of 'Reishit Chochmah' (Beginning of

ההם בפרט תאמרו מזמור על נהרות ומזמור לאסף אלהים באו גוים ותוסיפו צדקה לעניים בימים אלו כפי מה שהיה ראוי לכם לאכול. ותקדימו ותחשיכו לבית הכנסת לעולם ובפרט בימי דין אלו. והנה סדורים לפניכם סדרים על חורבן בית קדשנו ותפארתנו. ותזהרו בימי התענית מהדברים אשר העלה בעל ר״ח בספרו דרשו משם וחיו. ותענית ערב ראש חודש במיעוט הלבנה עקר גדול לתקון שכינה[i] כמו שיבא בסוף מאמר ד׳ בעה״י. ואיך כל מעשי התורה והתפלה והמצוה נרשמים בשכינה הנה הוא מתבאר לפניכם בפ׳ ויקהל דף רי״ג עמוד ב׳ ואם חס ושלום תפרקו עול תורה ודאי יהיה לי עליכם תרעומת בעולם הזה ובבא חס ושלום ואם תאבו ושמעתם ועשיתם ככל המצוה אשר צויתי אתכם אתפאר מכם ומני ומנייכו יתקלס עילאה בעולם הזה ובעולם הבא עם כל ישראל אמן כן יהי רצון: [ii]

in particular, recite Psalm 137 ("By the rivers") and Psalm 79 ("O God, the nations have come"), and give additional charity to the poor on these days proportionate to what you would have properly eaten. Always arrive early and stay late at the synagogue, especially on these days of judgment. Behold, arrangements concerning the destruction of our Holy Temple and our glory are set before you. Be careful on fast days regarding those matters which the author of Reishit Chochmah raised in his book—seek guidance there and live. The fast on the eve of the New Moon during the waning of the moon is of great importance for rectifying the Divine Presence, as will be explained at the end of the fourth discourse, God willing. And how all deeds of Torah, prayer, and commandments are inscribed in the Divine Presence is explained before you in Parashat Vayakhel, page 213b. If, heaven forbid, you cast off the yoke of Torah, I will certainly have complaints against you in this world and the next, heaven forbid. But if you are willing to listen and fulfill all the commandments that I have instructed you, I will glory in you, and from me and from you the Most High will be praised[1] in this world and in the World to Come with all Israel. Amen, may it be His will.

פרק כ״ג

Chapter 23

פה יתבאר טעם למנהג שפיכת

Here the reason will be explained for the custom of

[1] The conclusion reflects a common feature of ethical wills where the father expresses hope that his children's righteous conduct will bring merit to him after death, creating a reciprocal relationship where both father and children benefit spiritually from the children's good deeds.

Wisdom), a popular ethical-kabbalistic work. The 'Sha'ar HaKedushah' (Gate of Holiness) is a section of this work dealing with sanctification of physical acts like eating and drinking.

[i] This refers to the practice of fasting on the day before the New Moon (Yom Kippur Katan or 'Minor Day of Atonement'), which gained prominence in kabbalistic circles. The waning moon symbolizes the diminished state of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) in exile, and fasting at this time was believed to contribute to its restoration.

[ii] Cf. Zohar Vayakhel 213b — This passage explains how all acts of Torah study, prayer and commandments leave spiritual impressions on the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), which is why the author refers to it as evidence for how human religious actions affect divine realms. | Cf. Reishit Chochmah, Sha'ar HaKedushah — The author refers to Reishit Chochmah's teachings about the mystical significance of eating, which includes detailed instructions on how to transform physical consumption into a spiritual act through proper intentions, blessings, and mindfulness. | Cf. Psalm 137 (By the rivers of Babylon) — The text prescribes reciting this psalm of mourning for Jerusalem after simple meals on fast days, creating a connection between personal asceticism and national grief over the destruction of the Temple. | Cf. Psalm 79 (O God, the nations have come) — This psalm is prescribed alongside Psalm 137 as part of the penitential practice on Mondays and Thursdays, emphasizing the theme of national calamity and the desecration of the Temple.

המים שבשכונת המת. כתב
הכלבו שהוא לסימן שידעו
שיש שם מקרה מות ולא יהיה
מודיע בפה ויהיה מוציא דבה.
ויש אומרים שהטעם הוא לפי
שמלאך המות מטיל במים טיפת
סם המות[i] אולי ירצה כי כיון
שניתן לו רשות אז מתגבר בכל
עז להפוך כחות החסד לרוגז
ודין. ובפרט כח מלאך המות
הממית ח״ל שהוא ע״י המחבל
שנבל שמו שאינו שורה אלא
במקום פסול. כי מנוול הוא
לכן י״ש המתים ח״ל נקראים
נבלה. ובפ׳ תרומה פי׳ למה
בלוז אינו שולט בו מלאך המות.
ולמה לא נבנה שם ב״ה ולהיות
שמלאך המות גם אחר שעשה
שליחותו מבקש להגביר כח הדין
ולהפוך המים לדם. על כן אנו
שופכים המים על גבי קרקע
מקום מוצאם שאינם עלולים
לקבל טומאה שם. ובזה גם
כן מעוררים ומתפשטים מדת
החסד בעולם כמנהג אנשי החסד
השופכים לפניהם מים בימי
העצרה והתענית לשלטא ימינא
וכן לובשים לבנים לכוונה הזאת
ולבישת שחורים לאבלי ציון.
וסוד הגוונים שיחסו המקובלים
לספירות כי הנפש תעורר
לרוח ורוח לנשמה והנשמה
תעלה ממציאות למציאות עד
מקום יניקתה ואחיזתה ותעורר
לפי מציאות צירה וכשעור
ההזדמנו׳ העולה מלמטה כך
תעורר מלמעלה[ii] כדאמרי׳ על
יחוד השבח על ידי יסוד ובחול

pouring water in the vicinity of the deceased. The Kolbo writes that it serves as a sign so people will know that a death has occurred there, without needing to announce it verbally and thereby spreading rumors. Others say the reason is because the Angel of Death casts a drop of the poison of death into the water.[1] Perhaps this means that since the Angel has been given permission, it exerts all its power to transform the forces of loving-kindness into anger and judgment. This is especially true of the power of the Angel of Death that kills outside the Land of Israel,[2] which operates through the destroyer whose name is Naval ("vile"), who only dwells in an impure place. For he is defiled, therefore the dead outside the Land of Israel are called neveilah ("carcass"). In the portion Terumah, it explains why the Angel of Death has no power in [the city of] Luz, and why no synagogue was built there. And since the Angel of Death, even after completing its mission, seeks to strengthen the force of judgment and turn water into blood, we therefore pour the water onto the ground, their place of origin, where they are not susceptible to receiving impurity. Through this, we also awaken and spread the attribute of loving-kindness in the world, like the practice of kind-hearted people who pour water before themselves during times of drought and fast days to strengthen the right side[3] [of mercy]. Similarly, they wear white garments for this intention, and black garments for mourners of Zion. The secret of the colors that the Kabbalists attribute to the sefirot is that the nefesh (vital soul) awakens the ruach (spirit), the ruach awakens the neshamah (higher soul), and the neshamah ascends from one existence to another until it reaches its source and attachment. It awakens according to the nature of its form, and in proportion to the arousal rising from below, so it awakens from above, as we say regarding unification through

5R 10R 15R 20R 25R 30R 35R

[1] This reflects a Talmudic belief (Avodah Zarah 30b) that was integrated into folk practice. The concern about water being contaminated by the Angel of Death's poison led to various customs about discarding standing water near the deceased.

[2] The text makes a distinction between death in the Land of Israel versus elsewhere, reflecting the traditional Jewish belief that burial in Israel provides special spiritual benefits and protections.

[3] The 'right side' in Kabbalah refers to the attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness), associated with water. This passage reveals how ritual practices were designed to influence the balance of cosmic forces.

[i] This reflects a belief found in the Talmud (Avodah Zarah 30b) that the Angel of Death places a drop of poison in water, which is why water should be poured out if left uncovered overnight.

[ii] This expresses a fundamental kabbalistic principle known as 'itaruta d'letata' (awakening from

ע״י מטטרון שהשפע היורד הוא
כפי בחינת ההתעוררו׳ שעולה
אם מסוד נשמה יתירה בשבת ואם
מסוד ימי החול שאינו מעורר רק
כפי רוחניות עולם היצירה. וכל
שכן שבמעשה התחתון מעורר
לעומתו רוחניות עליון כדאמרו
שיצחק נעקד ביום הכפורים[i] ואז
החסד של מעלה עקד הדין
ומיכאל עקדו לגבריאל ואריה
יקד את השור וצדק עקדו
למאדים וכל דכותייהו הכי
נמי:[ii] גם הכהן איש החסד היה
לובש בד קדש ביום האדיר מדי
כניסתו ללובן העליון במחשבה
ובמעשה להלבין עונותיהם של
ישראל. ובעת שמסתלק האדם מן
העולם המקטרג מבקש לעורר
מדת הדין עליו ועל משפחתו
ואנו כנגדו מרבים שלום בעולם
על כלם ועל בני שכונתו. עוד
נוכל לומר כי המלאך בעצמו
הוא רוח כדכתיב עושה מלאכיו
רוחות ומלאכים שהם רוח הם
יותר חצונים מאותם שהם של
אש שלכן אמרו שמלאכי רוח
אינם יכולים ליכנס לפנים מפני
רוח הטומאה ועל כן בלילה
שכל הכוכבים המאירים ברקיע
לעולם מודים ומשבחים להקב״ה
וכן המלאכים העליונים כלם
מתחלקים לשלש משמרות ואינם
יכולים להתקרב אל המלך עד
שדוחים מהם רוח הטומאה ואז

praise by way of Yesod (Foundation), and on weekdays through Metatron, for the divine flow descending is according to the quality of the awakening that rises[1]—whether from the mystery of the additional soul on Sabbath, or from the mystery of weekdays, which awakens only according to the spirituality of the World of Formation. All the more so that a lower action awakens its corresponding higher spirituality, as they said that Isaac was bound on Yom Kippur, and then the heavenly loving-kindness bound judgment, and Michael bound Gabriel, and the lion bound the ox, and Jupiter bound Mars, and similarly with all their counterparts. Also, the priest, a man of loving-kindness, would wear sacred linen on the awesome day [Yom Kippur] whenever entering into the Supernal Whiteness, in thought and deed, to whiten the sins of Israel. And at the time when a person departs from the world, the accuser seeks to arouse the attribute of judgment against him and his family,[A] and we, in opposition, increase peace in the world for all of them and for the people of his neighborhood. We can further say that the angel itself is a spirit, as it is written, "He makes His angels spirits," and angels who are of spirit are more external than those who are of fire. Therefore, they said that angels of spirit cannot enter within because of the spirit of impurity. Thus, at night, when all the stars that illuminate the firmament forever acknowledge and praise the Holy One, blessed be He, and likewise the supernal angels all divide into three watches and cannot approach the King until they push away from themselves the spirit of impurity. Then, sixty myriad holy angels descend and cast sleep upon all inhabitants of the world, thereby pushing away the spirit of

[A] Or: "the prosecutor seeks to awaken the attribute of strict justice against him and his family" — The term 'mekatreg' specifically refers to a spiritual prosecutor or accuser, and 'midat ha-din' could be more precisely rendered as 'strict justice' to emphasize its unmitigated quality.

[1] This describes the kabbalistic principle of correspondence between human actions and divine response, known as 'itaruta d'letata' (awakening from below) and 'itaruta d'le'eila' (awakening from above).

below), which holds that human actions in the physical world create corresponding reactions in the spiritual realms.

[i] This refers to a rabbinic tradition that the binding of Isaac (Akedah) took place on Yom Kippur, and the author extends this to describe how this event created cosmic bindings between opposing forces in the spiritual realms.

[ii] The author presents a complex system of correspondences between biblical events, divine attributes, angelic beings, and astrological forces, showing how actions in one realm affect parallel entities in other realms.

יורדים ששים רבוא מלאכים
קדושים ומפילים שינה על כל
באי עולם ובזה דוחים רוח
הטומאה מעולם תחתון שהיא
שולטת על הישנים אבל לא
בא״י וכיון שרוח הטומאה נפרש
מהם עולים לפני הק״בה לשבח.
וכן ישראל לתתא אינם יכולים
להתאחד בקודשא בריך הוא
עד שדוחים סטרא אחרא מהם
בנתינת לה חלק לעסוק בה
בשער התפלין ובודוי בתפלה כי
ס״מ נוטל אותם העונות ונוטל
אותם על ראשי חייליו ומסתלק
בזה. ובתחלת הלילה שולט רוח
דרום בעולם כדי לדחות אינון
רוחין ודינין וזינין בישין דשלטי
אז בגין דיכיל עלמא למסבל.
והתעוררותם לשלוט אינו אלא
ברוח מערב השולט בתחלת
הלילה. הנה כי מלאך המות הוא
ממלאכי רוח שהם יותר חצונים
ממלאכי אש. החרב שבידו הוא
כח האש דין קשה שבו מתלבש
מלאך המות. האדם השולט בו
יסודו מעפר וכתיב כי עפר
אתה ולהיות כי גבר שליטתו
בג׳ יסודות הנזכרות מבקש ג״כ
להתגבר ביסוד המים שהוא נגד
חסד על כן אמרו שמטיל שם סם
המות שמצד הכח והרשות שניתן
לו להמית ידיו רב לו להגביר
ג״כ על יסוד המים. ואמרו
שלימים קדמוניות היו פעמים
בני אדם מתים בשתיית המים או
באכילתן מפני הרוח רע ששורה
עליהם. ובעת ששותה מהם
מזיק אותו. ולזה מנהג לשפוך
מים קודם שישתו בההוא שידא
דאמר אי ידענא דרגליתו בהכי
לא אשתהאי. וכן ממה שאמרו
שברירי ברירי ריר נראה שהיה
דרך רוחות רעות לעמוד על פני
המים ופעמים שכל דבר מתגבר

impurity from the lower world, which rules over those who sleep—though not in the Land of Israel. And once the spirit of impurity is separated from them, they ascend before the Holy One, blessed be He, to offer praise. Similarly, Israel below cannot unite with the Holy One, blessed be He, until they push away the Other Side from themselves by giving it a portion to occupy it, in the section on tefillin and in confession during prayer, for Samael takes those sins and places them on the heads of his forces and departs with this. At the beginning of the night, the south wind rules in the world in order to push away those spirits, judgments, and evil types that rule then, so that the world can endure. Their awakening to rule is only through the west wind that dominates at the beginning of the night. Indeed, the Angel of Death is among the angels of spirit, who are more external than the angels of fire. The sword in his hand is the power of fire, harsh judgment, in which the Angel of Death is clothed. Man, who is dominated by it, has his foundation in dust, as it is written, "For you are dust." And since his dominion has grown strong over the three elements mentioned,[A] he also seeks to overpower the element of water, which corresponds to loving-kindness. Therefore, they said that he casts the poison of death there, because from the power and authority given to him to cause death, his hands have enough power to also strengthen against the element of water. They said that in ancient times, people sometimes died from drinking water or eating because of the evil spirit that rested upon them. And when one would drink from them, it would harm him. For this reason, there is a custom to pour out water before drinking, like that demon who said, "Had I known you behave this way, I would not have lingered." And also from what they said about "Shabriri, Briri, Riri," it appears that evil spirits would stand over the waters, and sometimes each thing grows stronger against its opposite. Additionally, the pouring of water serves as an instruction to people to recognize the vanity of worldly matters, for even water that purifies and is essential for all human needs is not considered a small thing compared to the world after death. For the end of

[A] Or: "And since his control has prevailed over the three aforementioned elements" — This alternate translation more directly conveys the sense of the Angel of Death's progressive conquest of the elemental forces, emphasizing the sequential nature of his domination.

נגד הפכו. עוד תהיה שפיכת
המים הוראה לבני האדם כי
יהבילו ענייני העוה״ז כי אפילו
המים המטהרים והם הכרחיים
לכל צרכי בני אדם אינם נחשבים
לדבר קל מהעולם שאחר המות
כי סוף החיים הם כמים הנגרים
ארצה והכל כלה ואבד רק
נפשות חסידיו שלעולם נשמרו
בגין דהאי עלמא הוא חולקא
דס״א ועלמא דאתי הוא סטרא
דקדושה עוה״ז הוא לרשעים.
ועוה״ב הוא לצדיקים: ולכן
הקב״ה מאריך אפו לרשעים
בעוה״ז שהוא חלקם כ״כ בזהר
פ׳ פקודי דף רכ״ג ע״ב. עוד
שפיכת המים על העפר יבשר
ויודיע שעתיד הקב״ה לגבול
עפרו בטל העליון ויבא כגשם
לנו בשפע וכמלקוש יורה ארץ
ולהיותו קורץ מעפר זה סבת
מיתת האדם כי הוא מעלמא
דנוקבא. וכתוב בס׳ הזוהר
פ׳ וישלח דף ר״ט למה אליהו
עלה בסערה ולא מת לפי שהיה
נפשו מאילן החיים ולא מן ההוא
עפ״ר. דהות נשמתיה מרעותא
דדכורא יתיר משאר בני נשא
בגין כך כתיב וילך אל נפשו
דהוא דכורא ולא כתיב את
נפשו דהוא נוקבא[i] ברם משה
אתגזר מאתר דלא אתגזר ב״נ
אחרא בסוד כי מן המים משיתהו.
הנה כי סוד המים רומז להויה
ומציאות נבחר מן העפר כי הוא
היסוד הראשון בשנים התחתונים
והעפר יסוד האחרון וכולהו
עבדי ביה עבידתייהו כנדרש

life is like water poured out on the ground,[A] and everything is consumed and lost except the souls of His pious ones, which are preserved forever. This is because this world is the portion of the Other Side, while the World to Come is the side of holiness. This world is for the wicked, and the World to Come is for the righteous. Therefore, the Holy One, blessed be He, extends His patience to the wicked in this world, which is their portion, as stated in the Zohar, Parashat Pekudei, page 223b. Furthermore, pouring water on the dust announces and informs that in the future, the Holy One, blessed be He, will mix His dust with the supernal dew, and it will come to us abundantly like rain, and like the latter rain that waters the earth. Being formed from dust is the cause of human death, for it is from the feminine realm. It is written in the Zohar, Parashat Vayishlach, page 209, why Elijah ascended in a storm and did not die: because his soul was from the Tree of Life and not from that dust. His soul was from the masculine desire, more so than other people,[1] and because of this it is written, "And he went to [el] his soul," which is masculine, and not "to [et] his soul," which would be feminine. However, Moses was cut from a place from which no other person was cut, according to the secret meaning of "For from the water I drew him." Here is the secret: water alludes to a state of being and existence that is more refined than dust, for it is the first of the lower elements, while dust is the last element, and all perform their function through it, as expounded in Chapter 21.

120R 125R 130R 135R 140R 145R

[A] Or: "For the conclusion of life is like waters spilled upon the earth" — This alternate translation echoes 2 Samuel 14:14, which this phrase seems to reference, providing a closer biblical parallel that would be recognized by the intended audience.

[1] The text distinguishes between masculine and feminine spiritual qualities, with the masculine associated with active giving (like the prophet Elijah) and the feminine with receiving (like most humans). This gendered metaphysics is central to kabbalistic thought.

[i] The author interprets subtle grammatical differences in biblical Hebrew to reveal mystical meanings: using the preposition 'el' (to/toward) rather than 'et' (direct object marker) indicates masculine versus feminine qualities of the soul.

בפרק כ״א: [i]

פרק כ״ד

Chapter 24

טעם שהחמירו חכמים בשמירת
המתים שפטורים מקריאת שמע
ותפלה אם אינם שנים שזה משמר
וזה קורא הוא כי בראות רוח
5 הטומאה כלי טהור פנוי מרוח 5R
הקדושה אז בא ושורה בו וכל
אשר באהלו טמא ומטמא וטומאת
אהל חמורה מכלם כי מתפשטת
למעלה ולמטה כשיש פותח טפח
10 ובכל סביביו דקיימא עליה 10R
ככסלא לאוגייא. וכפי רוחניותה
כך טומאתה כי ידיה רב לה
להתפשט וטומאת משא למטה
ממנה שמטמאת בגדיה גם כן
15 כי בזה קופצת עליו ומטמאו 15R
עם בגדיו שכן היא והתלבשות
שלה טמא. ברם אינה מתפשטת
כטומאת אהל אבל טומאת מגע
והיסט כלי והם מיני קליפות
20 ורוחות חלוקות זו מזו כדפירשו 20R
הגאונים בספריהם[ii] כי יש שלשה
כתות נמשכים מהטומאה לא
ראי זה כזה וכן יש ג׳ כתות של
מלאכי חבלה ואין לנו חלק ולא
25 ידיעה בדברים אלו. ואוי ואבוי 25R
למי שנוטה אחריהם והתורה
הרחיקה אותנו מזה בכמה
מקומות וטומאות חלו הרבה

The reason why the Sages were stringent regarding the guarding of the dead, exempting [the guardians] from reciting the Shema and prayer unless there are two people, so that one guards while the other recites, is because when the spirit of impurity sees a pure vessel empty of the spirit of holiness, it enters and dwells within it. Everything in its tent becomes impure and transmits impurity, and the impurity of the tent is the most severe of all, as it spreads upward and downward when there is an opening the size of a handbreadth, and in all its surroundings, standing over it like a basket over a container.[A] And according to its spirituality, so is its impurity, for it has great power to spread.

The impurity of carrying [the dead] is of a lesser degree, as it renders one's garments impure as well, for in this case, it leaps upon the person and makes him and his garments impure, since both the impurity and its embodiment are impure. However, it does not spread like tent impurity. The impurities of touch and moving [the dead] are even lighter, and these are different types of negative forces and spirits distinct from one another, as the Geonim have explained in their books that there are three groups stemming from impurity, each unlike the other. Similarly, there are three groups of destructive angels, and we have no portion or knowledge of these matters. Woe to one who is drawn after them, for the

[A] Or: "like a cover over a vessel" — The Aramaic phrase 'ככסלא לאוגייא' is obscure and difficult to translate precisely. While 'basket over a container' conveys the general meaning of something covering another item, 'cover over a vessel' might be a more literal rendering of the metaphor being used to describe how impurity encompasses its surroundings.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The text cites this Zohar passage to support the idea that God is patient with the wicked in this world because this world is their only portion, while the righteous have the World to Come. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayishlach — This reference explains why Elijah didn't die but ascended in a whirlwind—because his soul originated from the Tree of Life rather than from dust, making him more connected to the masculine divine aspect than typical humans. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The text refers to this section of the Zohar when discussing the city of Luz where the Angel of Death had no dominion, showing the author's tendency to incorporate Zoharic teachings throughout his explanation of customs. | Cf. Sefer HaKolbo — The author cites the Kolbo (a medieval compendium of Jewish law) as the source for one explanation of the water-pouring custom: that it serves as a signal that a death has occurred without having to announce it verbally.

[ii] The author references the Geonim (post-Talmudic rabbinical authorities from approximately 589-1038 CE) as his source for the concept of three different categories of impurity. This shows how he integrates earlier rabbinic authorities into his kabbalistic framework.

מהם מתפשטים על הגוף להיותו
כלי שנשתמש בו קדש כי תאותם
להריח בקדושה לעשוק אהב.
ולכן המתים צריכים שמירה
כדי שלא יכנס בהם רוח רעה
כי הם תאבים להשלמת יצירתם
שלא נבראו להם גופות. ועיין
למה לא נבראו גופות לאלו
בפרשת בראשית ובזהר רות.
ובזה יש רמז דכשמתקלקלין
צנורות של מעלה משתנים סדרי
בראשית ואז כחות הטומאה
נכנסים באהל של מעלה וראתה
באו מקדשה[i] וכו׳. ועל אותה
שעה כתיב רגליה יורדים מות
אוי להם לבריות הגורמים לה
העדר הברכה. וזהו סוד אדם
כי ימות באהל. ובאידרת נשא
דף קמ״ד ע״ב אמר טעם איסור
שהיית המת בלילה אם אינו
להכין לו ארון ותכריכין וכן
בפ׳ נח דף ס״ו. עוד מזה בפ׳
ויקהל דף רנ״ט ובפ׳ ויחי דף
רכ״ד ע״ב ועיין בסוד הלבושים
פ׳ לך לך דף קס״ט ובדף קע״ב
ביאר טעם הספד שעושים הנשים
למת. ונתבאר בפ׳ בראשית דף
נ״ב למה המת מטמא ואמר כי
אדם הראשון בחטאו גירש א״ת
שהוא הקדושה מן הגן[ii] והוא
אדם השכין מקדם לג״ע את
הכרובים כי סתם אורחין
ושבילין[iii] ואמשיך קללות מן
היום ההוא והלאה ולחט החרב
הם מדרגות תחתונים השורים
בדין על העולם לשמור דרך
עץ החיים כדי שלא יוסיפו
לחטוא ובחטאו החשיך עליו
רוח הטומאה מצד הנחש המטמא
ושלכן המת מטמא כי הנחש

Torah has distanced us from this in many places.

Many of these impurities spread to the body because it is a vessel that was used for holiness, as their desire is to inhale holiness—they love to plunder. Therefore, the dead require guarding so that evil spirits cannot enter them, for these spirits crave to complete their formation since bodies were not created for them. See why bodies were not created for these [spirits] in the portion of Genesis and in the Zohar on Ruth.

This hints that when the supernal channels become corrupted, the orders of creation change, and then the forces of impurity enter the supernal tent, "and her pursuers have entered her sanctuary, etc." Concerning that time, it is written, "Her feet descend to death"—woe to the creatures who cause her to lack blessing. This is the secret of "When a person dies in a tent."

In the Idra of Naso, page 144b, the reason is given for the prohibition against keeping a corpse overnight unless it is to prepare a coffin and shrouds for it, and similarly in the portion of Noah, page 66. More on this is found in the portion of Vayakhel, page 259, and in the portion of Vayechi, page 224b. See also the secret of the garments in the portion of Lech Lecha, page 169, and on page 172, where the reason for the women's eulogy for the dead is explained.

It is explained in the portion of Genesis, page 52, why the dead person is impure. It states that Adam, through his sin, exiled "ET" (which is holiness) from the garden, and it was he, Adam, who caused the placement of the cherubim east of the Garden of Eden, for he blocked the paths and ways, and drew curses from that day onward. "The flaming sword" refers to the lower levels that dwell in judgment over the world, to guard the way to the Tree of Life so that they would not continue to sin. Through his sin, the spirit of impurity from the defiling serpent darkened upon him, and this is why the dead are impure—because the serpent extracted his soul

[i] This is a reference to Lamentations 1:10, which describes the destruction of the Temple. Here it is repurposed in a mystical context to describe how impurity invades sacred spaces when the divine channels are corrupted.

[ii] The term "א״ת" (Aleph-Tav) is significant in Kabbalah, representing the entirety of creation from the first letter of the Hebrew alphabet to the last. Here it symbolizes holiness itself being exiled from Eden through Adam's sin.

[iii] "He blocked the paths and ways" refers to the kabbalistic concept that Adam's sin obstructed the channels through which divine influence flows into the world, creating spiritual barriers that persist until the messianic redemption.

הוציא נשמתו וטימא גופו. אז
70 ניתן רשות לכל צדדי הטומאה
לשלוט על אותו הגוף. וכן
בלילה בעת השינה ולכן צריך
לשמירה. ולהיות שיש בחות
במזיקים המתקנאים בבני אדם
75 לכן אמרו שלשה צריכים שמירה
וא׳ מהם הוא חתן ויש אומרים
אף תלמיד חכם בלילה כי
מתקנאים בהם וחולה וחיה דריע
מזלייהו. ואמרי שבבא לאדם
80 צרה או חולי ב״מ כשבא לבקש
רחמים עליו מיד מזדמנים שם
אותם שניתן להם רשות להחליאו
או להביא עליו הצער ההוא.
ולכן צריך להתחזק בתפלתו
85 נגדם ולהסירם בתשובתו מלפני
שופט צדק לבל יחרצו לשונם
נגדו. וסמאל לעולם רודף אחר
זכות ותפלתן של ישראל כנץ
אחר היונה. וזהו אמר אויב
90 ארדוף אשיג וסבור לחלוק שלל
לאגפיו החצונים עמה שיונק
בשכינה מזוהמת הנחש. ואין
הטומאה יכולה לעלות רק עד
מדרגה הששית[i] ראשונה המת
95 הוא אבי אבות שני לו אב שלישי
לו ראשון רביעי לו שני בחולין
חמישי לו שלישי בתרומה ששי
לו רביעי בקדש כדתנן במסכת
טהרות. והמדרגה השביעית היא
100 מדת המים מקור מים חיים: לכן
יש כח במים לבטל הטומאה כי
עדיה אינה יכולה להגיע במקום
כבודם אך בצאתם ממקורם גם
הם מעותדים לטומאה אך היא
105 טומאה קלה כי יש להם טהרה
בהשקה כי בחזרתן למקורם בכל
דהו פרח טומאה מנייהו. וטעם
הכשרתם לזרעים לקבל טומאה
הוא שלפי חבתן טומאתן ובעודם

and defiled his body. At that point, permission was granted to all aspects of impurity to rule over that 70R
body. Similarly, at night during sleep, protection is required.

Since there are forces among the harmful entities that are jealous of human beings, the Sages said that three [types of people] require protection: one 75R
of them is a bridegroom, and some say even a Torah scholar at night, for they are jealous of them, as well as a sick person and a woman in childbirth, whose fortune is weakened. They say that when trouble or illness, God forbid, comes to a person, when he comes 80R
to seek mercy for himself, those who were given permission to make him ill or bring that suffering upon him immediately appear there. Therefore, one must strengthen one's prayer against them and remove them through repentance from before the righteous 85R
Judge, so they will not sharpen their tongues against him. Samael always pursues the merit and prayers of Israel like a hawk after a dove. This is what is meant by "The enemy said: 'I will pursue, I will overtake,'" thinking to divide the spoil with his external forces, 90R
along with what he draws from the Divine Presence from the contamination of the serpent.

Impurity can ascend only up to the sixth level. First, the corpse is the primary source of impurity; second to it is the father [of impurity]; third to it is 95R
the first [degree of impurity]; fourth to it is the second [degree] in non-sacred food; fifth to it is the third [degree] in terumah [priestly offering]; sixth to it is the fourth [degree] in sacred items, as we learned in Tractate Taharot. The seventh level is the attribute 100R
of water, the source of living waters.

Therefore, water has the power to nullify impurity, for impurity cannot reach water's place of honor. But when waters leave their source, they too are susceptible to impurity,[A] though it is a light impu- 105R
rity, as they can be purified through connection [to their source], for when they return to their source, even in the smallest amount, impurity departs from them. The reason they enable seeds to receive im-

[A] Or: "designated for impurity" — The Hebrew 'מעותדים' comes from the root meaning 'prepared' or 'designated'. While 'susceptible' conveys the meaning adequately in context, 'designated for impurity' captures more of the sense that there is an inherent potential or readiness in the waters to receive impurity once they leave their source.

[i] This establishes an important kabbalistic principle that impurity can only ascend through six levels but cannot reach the seventh level, which corresponds to the divine attribute of water (representing mercy and purification). This is why ritual purification involves water.

במקום כבודם ימין ה׳ רוממה לדחות משם כל נגע וכל מחלה וסרך טומאה ולכן גם למטה המים בעודם מחוברים בקרקע אינם מקבלים טומאה וכנגד זה מנו חכמים שש מעלות במקואות זו למעלה מזו. עוד יש למעלה מעלה סוד המקור והמבוע נהרא דמכיפיה מיברך[i] אשר עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך. ובפ׳ תרומה דף קצ״ח מתבאר מהו צד הטומאה זה השולט בארץ ולמה הוא סובב סביב לקדושה ע״ש כי הפליא לדבר:[ii]

purity is that according to their preciousness is their impurity, and while they are in their place of honor, "the right hand of the Lord is exalted" to repel all affliction, disease, and trace of impurity. Therefore, even in the lower realm, waters that are still connected to the ground do not receive impurity. Corresponding to this, the Sages enumerated six levels of ritual baths, each superior to the next.

Beyond the highest level is the secret of the source and the spring, "a river whose waters never fail,"[A] which "no eye has seen, O God, besides You." In the portion of Terumah, page 198, it is explained what this aspect of impurity is that rules in the earth and why it surrounds holiness—see there, for it speaks wondrously on the matter.

פרק כ״ה

יזהר האדם הרוחץ המת שלא יעזוב טנוף על בשרו וכן המעיין בקבר המת ומשכיבו יזהר שלא יהיה טפר על פניו שיש לו בושת משאר מתים כי הנפשות הם כתואר הגופים.[iii] ומצאתי שאין לעטוף המת אלא בטלית של

Chapter 25

The person washing the deceased should be careful not to leave any dirt on the body. Similarly, one who arranges the deceased in the grave should ensure there is no dust on the face, as the deceased feels shame before other dead, because souls retain the appearance of their bodies. I have found that one should wrap the deceased only in a white woolen

[A] Or: "a river that is blessed from its banks" — This Aramaic phrase is challenging to translate precisely. My translation attempts to capture the meaning contextually, but a more literal rendering might be 'a river that is blessed from its banks' or 'a river that is blessed from its source,' referring to a self-replenishing spring or wellspring.

[i] This Aramaic phrase refers to the mystical concept of a self-replenishing river or spring, symbolizing the divine source that continuously renews itself. It may allude to the river flowing from Eden in Genesis 2:10.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The text cites this specific passage in the Zohar to explain why a corpse should not be kept overnight. This reference is integral to the argument about how impurity operates and why guarding the dead is necessary. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Bereshit — This reference connects corpse impurity to Adam's original sin, explaining how his actions caused the spirit of impurity to enter the world through the serpent. This Zoharic passage provides the mystical foundation for understanding why death causes ritual impurity. | Cf. Idra of Naso — The Idra of Naso is cited as an authoritative source for the prohibition against keeping a corpse overnight. This esoteric section of the Zohar deals with profound mystical concepts regarding life, death, and the spiritual cosmos. | Cf. Exodus 15:9 — The phrase "The enemy said: 'I will pursue, I will overtake'" is a direct quote from the Song at the Sea. Here it is reinterpreted in a kabbalistic context to refer to Samael (a satanic figure) pursuing the prayers and merits of Israel to prevent them from ascending. | Cf. Tractate Taharot — The text references the rabbinic system of degrees of ritual impurity as outlined in Tractate Taharot, using this halakhic framework to explain the mystical concept of how impurity operates in different levels or realms. | Cf. Proverbs 5:5 — The phrase "Her feet descend to death" is from Proverbs, originally referring to the strange woman/harlot. In this kabbalistic context, it's reinterpreted to refer to the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) when the channels of blessing are corrupted by human sin.

[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that souls retain the appearance of their bodies after death, which explains why proper preparation of the body is important—the soul remains aware of and affected by the treatment of its physical vessel.

צמר לבן דכתיב לבושיה כתלג חיור. ועיין בתקון י׳ דף כ״א ע״ב כוונת הציצית. ומשם תבין טעם לבישת הטלית למת בסוד שרפים עומדים וגו׳ וכבר כתבנו מזה למעלה. ובתקון י״ח דף כ״ט ע״ב אמר כי מקיימי מצות ציצית לכסות השכינה מבעלי הדין הקב״ה מני למלאכא מרכבתא לנטלא לון בגדפייהו ולפרחא בהון מאתר לאתר ולכסאה עליהון מכל מזיקין ומלאכי חבלה. ונראה לעניות דעתי כי מי שהנהיג עצמו לשום אזוב על שלחנו בשבת[i] בסעודי דמהימנותא קדישא כאשר בא בקונטריסים שלנו שיהיה טוב לצרף עם הזיעים ומיני בשמים כשרוחצים אותו אחר מיתתו מעט אזוב עמהם שכבר ידוע כמה יפה כח האזוב לטהרת האדם. ואמר ר׳ שמעון בן יוחאי בפ׳ שמות דף ט״ו דלא שליט עליה שום ממנא בר קב״ה בלחודוי כדאמרי׳ גם כן על ד׳ מינים שבלולב ומיני תבואה שלכן מברכים המוציא לחם מן הארץ הוא בעצמו ובכבודו. ובתוב בפ׳ יתרו בכל אתר דבעי קב״ה לדכאה לבר נש באזובא מתדכי מ״ט משום דיתער חיליה מלעילא דאתפקדא עלוהי דחילא דא כד אתתער מבערא רוח מסאבא

tallit,[1] as it is written: "His garment was white as snow"[A2] [Daniel 7:9]. See Tikkun 10, folio 21b, regarding the meaning of tzitzit (ritual fringes). From there you will understand the reason for placing a tallit on the deceased, connected to the mystical concept of "seraphim standing" [Isaiah 6:2], as we have explained above. In Tikkun 18, folio 29b, it states that for those who fulfill the commandment of tzitzit to cover the Divine Presence from the forces of judgment,[3] the Holy One, blessed be He, commands the chariot angels to lift them with their wings, to carry them from place to place, and to shield them from all harmful spirits and destructive angels.

It seems to me, in my humble opinion, that for one who was accustomed to place hyssop on his table during Sabbath meals of holy faith,[B] as mentioned in our treatises, it would be good to include some hyssop with the spices and fragrant herbs when washing him after death. The power of hyssop for human purification is well known. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai stated in Parashat Shemot, folio 15, that no celestial appointee has dominion over it except the Holy One, blessed be He, alone, just as we also say regarding the four species of the lulav and various grains, which is why we bless "Who brings forth bread from the earth"—He Himself in His glory.

It is written in Parashat Yitro that in every place where the Holy One, blessed be He, wishes to purify a person with hyssop, they become purified. Why? Because it awakens its power from above, where this power is entrusted. When this power is awakened, it drives away the spirit of impurity, and the person is purified. Thus, purification through hyssop

[A] Or: "like white snow" — This is a more literal translation of the Aramaic phrase from Daniel 7:9, maintaining the comparative structure of 'like white snow' rather than 'white as snow.'

[B] Or: "meals of sacred faith" — While this phrase typically refers to Sabbath meals in kabbalistic contexts, the text doesn't explicitly mention Sabbath here, only that the practice occurs on Sabbath. A more direct translation might omit the specific Sabbath reference.

[1] The text specifies wool (צמר) as the material for the tallit, reflecting the traditional preference for woolen tallitot, particularly for burial purposes.

[2] This is a reference to Daniel 7:9, describing the Ancient of Days. The author connects the white burial garment to divine attributes.

[3] The original 'בעלי הדין' literally means 'masters of judgment' but refers to the celestial forces or entities that execute divine judgment. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that tzitzit serve as spiritual protection.

[i] The practice of placing hyssop on one's Sabbath table was a custom among some kabbalists, believed to enhance spiritual purification and protection during sacred meals.

ואתדכי בר נש.[i] ואם כן טהרה על ידי האזוב מועיל לכל בר נש. ויותר יערב ויבושם לו ולנשמתו של אותו שבקש לטהר עצמו בו בחייו ולהבריח מאהלו ומשלחנו אותם המחשיכים פני הבריות בקטרוגם. ועץ ארז ואזוב רומז לקב״ה ושכינת עזו והוא כטעם האתרוג עם הלולב ואזוב רומז לגן ה׳ שמשם יזובו כל נפשות הצדיקים והנשמה הקדושה כשתשיג מה שביכלתה תדבק בנפש העליונה ותפשוט מלבוש העפר מעליה ותדבק בשכינה. וזוהי מיתת נשיקה שהוא דבוק הנפש בשרשה[ii] בסוד ישקני מנשיקות פיהו. ולכן צדיקים המתים בענין זה אינם מטמאים[iii] כאשר בארנו לעיל:[iv]

benefits every person. It will be even more pleasing and fragrant to the soul of one who sought to purify himself with it during his lifetime, driving away from his tent and table those who darken the countenance of creatures with their accusations. 45R

The cedar wood and hyssop symbolize the Holy One, blessed be He, and His mighty Divine Presence, similar to the etrog with the lulav. The hyssop specifically symbolizes the Garden of God,[1] from which flow all the souls of the righteous. When the holy soul attains what it can, it cleaves to the supernal soul, removes its earthly garment, and adheres to the Divine Presence. This is "death by divine kiss,"[A] which is the cleaving of the soul to its root, in the mystical sense of "Let Him kiss me with the kisses of His mouth" [Song of Songs 1:2]. Therefore, the righteous who die in this manner do not transmit ritual impurity, as we have explained above. 50R 55R

והמתקדשים והמטהרים עצמם לפחות בשלש רגלים ובראש

Those who sanctify and purify themselves at least during the three pilgrimage festivals, Rosh 60R

[A] Or: "death of the kiss" — A more literal translation of this kabbalistic concept, though 'death by divine kiss' better conveys the meaning to English readers unfamiliar with this mystical concept.

[1] In kabbalistic symbolism, hyssop's association with the Garden of God refers to its role as a conduit between earthly and divine realms, facilitating the soul's journey.

[i] The Zohar teaches that hyssop has special power to drive away 'ruach mesa'ava' (spirit of impurity), making it valuable both during life and in death rituals.

[ii] Death by divine kiss (mitat neshikah) was considered the highest form of death in kabbalistic tradition, where the soul departs directly through divine connection rather than through the Angel of Death. This was believed to be how Moses, Aaron, and Miriam died.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic belief that the perfectly righteous who die by 'divine kiss' do not transmit ritual impurity, as their death is a pure spiritual transformation rather than a result of the forces of impurity.

[iv] Cf. Tikkun 10 of Tikkunei Zohar — The text cites this passage to explain why the deceased is wrapped in a tallit, suggesting that the protective spiritual properties of the tallit with tzitzit continue to benefit the soul after death. | Cf. Tikkun 18 of Tikkunei Zohar — This reference supports the practice of burying the dead with a tallit, as it suggests that the protective qualities of the tzitzit continue to shield the soul even after death from accusers and negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shemot — The author cites this to establish the special purifying properties of hyssop, which are directly controlled by God rather than angelic intermediaries, making it especially effective for purification rituals including those for the deceased. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:2 — The text interprets this verse from Song of Songs mystically to explain the concept of 'death by divine kiss' (mitat neshikah), where the soul's departure occurs through direct connection with the divine rather than through the Angel of Death, representing the highest form of death reserved for the most righteous. | Cf. Daniel 7:9 — This biblical reference is used to justify the custom of wrapping the deceased in a white tallit, connecting the burial shroud to divine garments described in Daniel's vision, thereby suggesting that proper burial preparation helps align the deceased with divine attributes.

השנה ויום הכפורים[i] אם לא
בטבילת גופם במ׳ סאה[ii] כי זה
היה להם ודאי תקון בטהרה.
ברם לפחות מטילים על ראשם
או רובם תשעה קבין[iii] של מים
יראה לי שבכלל החסד של
אמת[iv] שיעשו עמו העוסקים
בטהרתו ביודעם שכך דרכו
בחייו הנה מה טוב כי בשטיפתו
וריקו על ראשו ועל כל גופו
ט׳ קבין שהם רי״ו בצים[v] כנגד
רי״ו אותיות שבשם הגדול
שלכן נקרא אריה. ובן אמה
על אמה הנאמר במקוה הוא
רי״ו טפחים ורום ג׳ אמות הם
גי׳ רי״ו שיוצאים מן ההוי״ה
כנדרש במקומו בתקוני התשובה
פרק י״א שכללם יחד תרח״ם
והוא סוד מקוה ישראל ה׳[vi] כי
שעור המקוה שהוא תרמ״ח

Hashanah, and Yom Kippur—if not by immersing their bodies in forty se'ah of water, which would certainly be an effective purification—but at least by pouring nine kav of water over their heads or most of their bodies: it seems to me that it should be included in the true kindness[A] that those engaged in his ritual purification should perform for him, knowing that this was his practice during his lifetime. How good it would be to pour and empty upon his head and his entire body nine kav, which equals 216 eggs, corresponding to the 216 letters in the great Name, which is therefore called "lion"[B] (אריה).[1] Similarly, the one-by-one-cubit measure mentioned regarding the ritual bath equals 216 handbreadths, and a height of three cubits has the numerical value of 216,[2] which derive from the Divine Name (YHVH) as explained in its place in the Rectifications of Repentance, chapter 11,[C] where together they total "You will have mercy"[D] (תרח״ם). This is the secret of "the Lord

65R 70R 75R 80R

[A] Or: "chesed shel emet" — The Hebrew term 'chesed shel emet' is sometimes kept untranslated in English texts about Jewish burial practices because it has become a technical term referring specifically to the kindness shown to the dead.

[B] Or: "ARI'eH" — This could be left untranslated as a Hebrew acronym representing the numerical value 216, which might better preserve the technical kabbalistic terminology. However, the translation as 'lion' is more accessible and reflects the actual meaning of the word.

[C] Or: "in Tikkunei HaTeshuvah, chapter 11" — Keeping the original Hebrew title might be more accurate for scholarly reference, but the translation provides better accessibility for readers unfamiliar with Hebrew.

[D] Or: "TRaCHeM" — The Hebrew word could be left as a transliteration to emphasize its function as a technical term in gematria calculations, but translating it conveys the meaning more clearly to general readers.

[1] This refers to a kabbalistic concept where the Hebrew word for 'lion' (אריה) has the numerical value of 216, which is the same as the number of letters in certain combinations of divine names. This gematria (numerical equivalence) creates a mystical connection between the lion as a symbol of divine power and the divine names themselves.

[2] The author is creating a series of numerical correspondences all centered on the number 216, connecting physical measurements of ritual objects (the mikveh dimensions) with divine names through gematria (Jewish numerology).

[i] The three pilgrimage festivals (Passover, Shavuot, and Sukkot) along with Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur were times when Jewish men traditionally immersed in a mikveh (ritual bath) for spiritual purification.

[ii] Forty se'ah is the minimum amount of water required for a valid mikveh (ritual bath) according to Jewish law.

[iii] Nine kav of water is a measure traditionally used for a partial purification when a complete immersion in a mikveh is not possible. This was particularly used by men for seminal emissions.

[iv] Chesed shel emet (true kindness) is a traditional term for activities performed for the dead, since they cannot reciprocate or thank the performers.

[v] The Hebrew letters רי״ו (reish, yod, vav) have the numerical value of 216 in gematria (Hebrew numerology).

[vi] This is a quote from Jeremiah 17:13 that creates a wordplay between 'mikveh' as a ritual bath and 'mikveh' meaning 'hope' or 'expectation.'

מפחים כשעור השם ומלת תרחם
הוא בגימטריא מצפ״ן מצפ״ן
85 הוי״ה טדה״ד או הוי״ה אהי״ה
עם הכולל. ויכוין לג׳ שמות
מלאים ביו״דין שהם ג׳ פעמים
שם ע״ב היוצאים משם ע״ב
ס״ג מ״ה[i] שהוא שם הוי״ה מלא
90 ביוד״ין וס״ג מלא ביודי״ן ואל״ף
ומ״ה מאלפין לבד. המטהרים
שם בן שבשבינה[ii] שהוא שם
הוי״ה מלא בהה״ן. ועוד יכוין
האדם המטהר עצמו בחייו כי
95 הוא מקבל על ראשו ועל גופו
שפע השעה מדות[iii] המריקים
עליו והוא במדרגת השבינה
ועם המשפיעים והמקבלים
הם עשר ובזה יכוונו גם אחר
100 מותו לטהרו ולקדשו. ושיעור
תשעה קבין שקלתי אותם פה
מודינה[iv] שמימיה קלים הרבה
והוא כמו שלשים ושמנה ליטרא
וחצי מים. ואם יהיו כבדים
105 יוצרך להוסיף עליהם כי טוב
להוסיף על צד היותר טוב

is the hope of Israel"[A] [Jeremiah 17:13], for the measure of the mikveh, which is 648 handbreadths, is equivalent to the numerical value of the Divine Name, and the word "You will have mercy" has the same numerical value as the Divine Names מצפ״ן 85R
הוי״ה אהי״ה or מצפ״ן הוי״ה טדה״ד with the inclusive count.[1]

One should also have in mind the three full Divine Names spelled with yods, which are three times the 72-letter Name that emerge from the Names 72, 90R
63, and 45—that is, the Divine Name YHVH spelled fully with yods, and the 63-Name spelled fully with yods and alef, and the 45-Name spelled with alefs only. These purify the 52-Name within the Divine Presence,[B] which is the Divine Name YHVH spelled 95R
fully with heis.[2]

Furthermore, a person who purifies himself during his lifetime should have in mind that he is receiving upon his head and body the flow of the nine attributes that are emptied upon him, and he is at 100R
the level of the Divine Presence, and together with those who bestow and those who receive, they are te[3]n. And with these intentions they should also purify and sanctify him after his death.

[A] Or: ""Mikveh Israel Hashem"" — Keeping the original Hebrew might better preserve the wordplay between 'mikveh' as ritual bath and 'mikveh' as hope, but the translation better conveys the meaning of the biblical verse.

[B] Or: "the Name Ban within the Shekhinah" — The alternate translation preserves the technical kabbalistic terminology (Ban is the name given to the 52-value divine name) and uses 'Shekhinah' rather than 'Divine Presence', which might be preferred in more technical kabbalistic contexts.

[1] These combinations of divine names are kabbalistic formulations used in mystical meditation. The 'inclusive count' (הכולל) is a technique in gematria that adds 1 to the total, representing the unity that encompasses all the letters.

[2] In Kabbalah, different spellings of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) have different numerical values and correspond to different divine aspects and spiritual worlds. The 52-Name (spelled with heis) is associated with Malkhut (Kingdom) and the Shekhinah (Divine Presence).

[3] This describes a kabbalistic understanding of ritual purification where the person becomes a vessel for divine attributes (sefirot). The nine attributes plus the person (as representative of the Shekhinah/Divine Presence) make ten, corresponding to the complete set of divine emanations in Kabbalah.

[i] These are kabbalistic references to specific spellings of the divine name YHVH, where each has a different numerical value: 72, 63, and 45 respectively.

[ii] The 'Name of 52 in the Shekhinah' refers to another spelling of the divine name with the numerical value of 52, associated with the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah).

[iii] The nine attributes likely refer to nine of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah, excluding Malkhut (Kingdom), which is often identified with the Shekhinah or divine presence mentioned in the next phrase.

[iv] Modena is a city in northern Italy where the author, Aaron Berechia of Modena, lived and served as a rabbi.

מלפחות אפי׳ קורטוב[i] שכל מדות חכמים הם מצומצמים ובארבעים סאה חסר קורטוב אינו יכול לטבול וכן יהיה בשיעור תשעה קבין שאפילו טפה אחת תעכב הטהרה. וישפכם על ראשו ועל רובו לאט לו ויכוין לטהרת נשמתו. [ii]

Regarding the measure of nine kav, I weighed them here in Modena, where the water is very light, and it is about thirty-eight and a half litra of water.[1] If the water is heavier, it would be necessary to add more, for it is better to add more than to have even a drop less, since all the measures established by the Sages are precise. In a ritual bath of forty se'ah, if it is missing even a tiny amount, one cannot immerse, and the same applies to the measure of nine kav, where even a single drop would hinder the purification. And one should pour it slowly over his head and most of his body, with the intention of purifying his soul.[2] 105R 110R 115R

הנשמה רואה בחייה לפעמים מה שעתידים לעשות לגוף לאחר מיתה שנאמר והעוף אוכל אותם מן הסל מעל ראשי[iii] והרי לא אכל העוף בשרו רק אחר שמת וקשה לנשמה זילות הגוף כדאמרו קשה רימה למת.[iv] ויש שרצו להסמיך מן התורה שהנשמה לאחר שמת האדם רואה מה שעושים לגוף. וכבר אמרנו שהנשמה אינה עולה עד שיקבר הגוף. ובשם שאין להראות

The soul sometimes sees during its lifetime what will be done to the body after death,[3] as it is said, "and the birds ate them from the basket above my head" [Genesis 40:17]—yet the birds did not eat his flesh until after he died. The degradation of the body is difficult for the soul, as they said, "the worm is painful to the dead."[A] Some have tried to find support in the Torah for the idea that after a person dies, the soul sees what is being done to the body. We have already stated that the soul does not ascend until the body is buried.[4] Just as one should not show a Torah scroll in the ark to an idolater, for 120R 125R

[A] Or: "as they said, "the worm causes distress to the deceased"" — This alternative translation uses more formal language and avoids the potentially confusing literal translation of physical pain, since the text is discussing a metaphysical concept of the soul's distress at bodily decomposition.

[1] The litra was a weight measure used in Italy during this period. The author is providing a practical measurement that would have been understood by his contemporary readers in Modena.
[2] This emphasizes that the ritual washing is not merely physical but has profound spiritual significance, purifying the soul of the deceased as it transitions to the afterlife.
[3] This introduces a mystical concept that the soul has prophetic awareness while still in the body, particularly regarding future treatment of the corpse.
[4] This reflects the kabbalistic view that the soul remains connected to the body until proper burial, during which time it experiences distress at any disrespect shown to the corpse.

[i] A kortov is a very small measure of liquid in rabbinic literature, emphasizing that even the tiniest deficiency in the required amount invalidates the ritual.
[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author is discussing ritual purification practices that should be performed for the deceased as part of the tahara (ritual washing) based on their practices during life | Cf. Jeremiah 17:13 — The author creates a wordplay between 'mikveh' (ritual bath) and 'mikveh' (hope) from Jeremiah to connect ritual purification with spiritual redemption | Cf. Tikkunei HaTeshuvah Chapter 11 — The author references another work that explains the kabbalistic significance of the numerical values related to ritual purification | Cf. Zohar — The text employs Zoharic-style explanations of divine names and their numerical equivalents, a hallmark of kabbalistic literature that influenced Ma'avar Yabok
[iii] This is a quote from Genesis 40:17, part of the chief baker's dream that Joseph interpreted. The author is using this as evidence that souls can foresee what will happen to their bodies after death.
[iv] This is a Talmudic saying (Berakhot 18b) meaning "the worm is painful to the dead," suggesting that the deceased maintain some awareness of what happens to their body after death.

ס״ת שבארון לעובד למולך
כי שם הוא תלוי המזל עליון
הנוזל רב טוב לבית ישראל
130 שעל כן נענש חזקיהו[i] כך אין
להראות לו המת בקבר כי שם
שוכב בכבו״ד ואין להשליט
בו עינא אחרא דפגעא.[ii] עוד
אמרו במדרש קהלת ובירושלמי
135 פרק אין מעמידין גם כן בשם
רבי זעירא ובשם ר׳ אשיאן
שהמת יודע ושומע קלוסו
כמתוך החלום. וכל שאומרים
בפניו הוא יודע עד שיסתם
140 הגולל וישוב אל העפר. וכן
אמר רב אחים לי בהספדאי
דהתם קאימנא[iii] והרבה חכמים
במס׳ מועד קטן שהיו אומרים
לספדניא ההוא יומא מאי
145 קאמרת. וההספד יקרא דחיי
ודשיכבי הוא כנודע. ובכלל
יקרא דשיכבי הוא גם כן מה
שנוהגים שכשאחד מקרובי המת
לא היה בקבורתו הולך לבית
150 הקברות לבקרו ואולי יש סמך
לזה ממה דתניא באבל רבתי
מעשה שמת שמעון בן יהוצדק
בלוד ובא יוחנן אחיו מן הגליל

therein depends the supreme destiny flowing abundant goodness to the House of Israel[1] (for which reason Hezekiah was punished), similarly one should not show the deceased in the grave, for there he lies in honor, and one should not allow the harmful "evil eye" to have power over him.[A] It is further stated in the Midrash on Ecclesiastes and in the Jerusalem Talmud, chapter "Ein Ma'amidin," in the name of Rabbi Zeira and Rabbi Ashian, that the dead person knows and hears his eulogy as if in a dream.[B] And everything said in his presence, he knows until the grave is sealed and he returns to dust. Thus Rabbi Achim said, "I will be present at my own eulogy," and many sages in Tractate Mo'ed Katan would ask the eulogizers on that day, "What did you say?" The eulogy is an honor to both the living and the dead,[2] as is known. Included in the honor of the dead is also the practice that when one of the deceased's relatives was not present at the burial, he goes to the cemetery to visit him.[C] Perhaps there is support for this from what is taught in Avel Rabbati: "There was an incident where Shimon ben Yehotzadak died in Lod, and his brother Yochanan came from the Galilee after the grave was sealed. They came and asked Rabbi Tarfon and the sages, who said that he should not defile himself [by having the grave reopened], but they should open the courtyard of the grave so he could

130R 135R 140R 145R 150R 155R

[A] Or: "and one should not subject him to the harmful gaze of others" — This alternative translation avoids the potentially confusing mystical terminology of "evil eye" for modern readers, while still conveying the concept of protecting the deceased from inappropriate or harmful viewing.

[B] Or: "the deceased is aware of and perceives his eulogy as through a dreamlike state" — This alternative uses more precise language about the state of consciousness being described, avoiding the potentially misleading implication that the dead literally 'hear' in the same way as the living.

[C] Or: "when a relative of the deceased was unable to attend the burial, it is customary for them to visit the gravesite afterward" — This alternative translation more clearly indicates that this is a normative practice rather than just a description, and uses gender-neutral language to make the guidance more inclusive.

[1] This mystical phrase refers to the Torah scroll as a conduit of divine blessing. The author draws a parallel between the sacred nature of Torah scrolls and the sanctity of the human body after death.

[2] This reflects the Jewish concept that proper eulogies serve multiple purposes: honoring the deceased, comforting the living, and inspiring ethical improvement.

[i] This refers to King Hezekiah who was punished for showing the treasures of his kingdom to Babylonian envoys (2 Kings 20:12-19), which eventually led to their conquest of Jerusalem. The author draws a parallel between improperly displaying sacred items and improperly displaying the deceased.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase refers to preventing harmful "evil eye" influences from affecting the deceased, reflecting the belief that inappropriate viewing of the dead could harm their soul.

[iii] This phrase quotes a Talmudic passage where Rabbi Achim states "I will be present at my own eulogy," supporting the idea that the deceased is aware of what is said at their funeral.

אחר שנסתם הגולל ובאו ושאלו
155 את רבי טרפון וחכמים ואמרו
אל יטמא אלא יפתחו חצר
הקבר ויראה[i] והביא ברייתא זו
הרשב״א בתשובה רצ״ב. הגם
שמנהג זה הוא מדברים שאלו לא
160 נכתבו ראוי להעשות משום יקרא
דשכבי ומשום נייחא דדעתא
דחיי.[ii]

see." The Rashba cited this baraita in responsum 292. Although this custom is among those things that if they had not been written down, it would still be proper to perform them for the honor of the deceased and for the peace of mind of the living.[1] 160R

וממה ששמעתי אומרים שהמת
יודע מענייני העה״ז קודם
165 רחיצתו יותר מאחר הרחיצה
נוכל לומר שברחיצה מרחיקים
ממנו ומנשמתו חומריות העה״ז
ואחר שמצואתו רוחץ מכאן
ואילך תאב ללבוש מחלצות
170 מכתנות אור מעין אויר גן עדן
תחתון[iii] בסוד וטהרו ואח״כ

From what I have heard people say that the dead know more about matters of this world before their washing than after it,[A] we can say that through washing, the materiality of this world is distanced from them and their souls. After being cleansed of impurity, from that point onward they desire to wear pure garments made of light, reminiscent of the atmosphere of the lower Garden of Eden,[B] in keeping with the mystical principle of "and they shall be pu- 165R 170R

[A] Or: "Based on what I have heard said, the deceased is more aware of worldly matters before the ritual washing than afterward" — This alternate translation uses 'the deceased' instead of 'the dead' for a more respectful tone, and 'ritual washing' explicitly indicates the Jewish tahara process. However, the original translation is more direct and faithful to the Hebrew text.

[B] Or: "the soul yearns to be clothed in luminous vestments, similar to the ethereal quality of the lower Paradise" — This alternate translation emphasizes the mystical dimension more strongly with terms like 'luminous vestments' and 'ethereal quality,' which might better capture the kabbalistic concept. 'Paradise' is used instead of 'Garden of Eden' as a variation, though both are acceptable translations.

[1] This concluding phrase emphasizes the dual purpose of Jewish burial practices: showing respect to the deceased while providing emotional closure for mourners.

[i] This describes a rabbinic ruling that balances two concerns: avoiding ritual impurity by not reopening a grave, while still allowing a relative who missed the funeral to see the burial site for closure.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 40:17 — The author uses this verse to prove that the soul can foresee what will happen to the body after death, since the baker saw in his dream what would happen to his body after execution. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Avodah Zarah — The Jerusalem Talmud is cited as a source for the teaching that the dead are aware of what is said about them before burial. | Cf. Midrash Kohelet (Ecclesiastes) — The Midrash on Ecclesiastes is cited alongside the Jerusalem Talmud as a source for the teaching that the dead are aware of what is said about them. | Cf. Tractate Mo'ed Katan — This Talmudic tractate is referenced to support the idea that sages were concerned about what was said in eulogies, implying the dead person would be aware of it. | Cf. 2 Kings 20:12-19 — The text alludes to Hezekiah being punished for showing the Babylonian messengers his treasures, comparing this to improperly displaying a deceased person in their grave. | Cf. Avel Rabbati (Semachot) — This minor tractate on mourning laws is cited to support the practice of allowing relatives who missed a burial to visit the grave for closure. | Cf. Rashba's Responsum 292 — The author notes that the Rashba (Rabbi Shlomo ben Aderet, 13th century) cited this teaching in his responsa, adding weight to the practice.

[iii] This is a reference to the kabbalistic concept of spiritual garments that the soul wears in the afterlife. The 'garments of light' (כתנות אור) contrast with the 'garments of skin' (כתנות עור) that Adam and Eve received after their expulsion from Eden. The ritual purification (tahara) is understood as beginning the soul's transition from physical to spiritual existence.

וקדשו[i] וזה לשון השגור בפי הכל שקוראים לרחיצה זו טהרה ובזה מתמעט ממנו השיח והשיג שהיה לו בענייני חמריות העה״ז. ובירושלמי דאין מעמידין כד דמך רבי נחום בר סימאי חפון איקונתא מחצלן[ii] פי׳ חיפו האקונין במחצלות אמרי כמה דלא חמתון בחיוהי לא יחמתון בדמיכותיה וחכמין אינון כלום אמר רשב״ל אין בינינו ולצדיקים אלא דבור פה בלבד. ובגמרין פרק ג׳ דמועד קטן גרסינן אשתעו כל צלמניא והוו למחצליא וכן בשבת פרק שואל. ומעובדי דבני ר׳ חייא דנפקו לקרייתא דכתיבי בפרק מי שמתו ומהנהו קפולאי דקפלי בארעא דרב נחמן בשבת. ומההוא אמגושא דהוה מחטט שכבי[iii] דבפרק חזקת הבתים נראה מכל אלו שיודעים ושיש להם ממשות ומרגישים בענייני העולם הזה ואפי׳ המתים שאינם תלמידי חכמים. אמר רבי אבהו כל מה שאומרים בפני המת יודע עד שיסתום הגולל פליגי בה רבי חייא בר אבא ורבי שמעון ברבי, חד אמר עד שיסתום הגולל וחד אמר עד שיתעכל הבשר. ובמסכת ברכות פרק מי שמתו האריך מידיעת המתים בדברי העה״ז מלבד השגתם בעה״ב. וכן במציעא פרק השובר בר״ל דהוה מציין מערתי דרבנן ואעלמא

rified” and afterward “and they shall be sanctified.” This is the common terminology used by everyone, who call this washing “purification” (tahara), and through this process, the discourse and perception that the deceased had regarding material matters of this world are diminished. 175R

In the Jerusalem Talmud, tractate Avodah Zarah, it is related that when Rabbi Nahum bar Simai died, they covered the statues with mats. This means they covered the images with mats, saying, “Just as he did not look at them during his lifetime, he should not see them in his death.” And are the dead aware of anything? Rabbi Shimon ben Lakish said: “Between us and the righteous, there is only the matter of speech alone.”[A] 180R 185R

In our Gemara, in the third chapter of Moed Katan, we learn that all the statues spoke and were covered with mats, and similarly in Shabbat, chapter “Sho’el.” And from the accounts of Rabbi Hiyya’s sons who went to the villages, as written in the chapter “Mi Shemeto,” and from those launderers who folded garments on Rabbi Nahman’s property on Shabbat, and from that magician who was exhuming corpses mentioned in the chapter “Hazakat HaBatim”—from all these cases it appears that the dead have knowledge, possess substance, and perceive matters of this world, even those deceased who were not Torah scholars. 190R 195R

Rabbi Abbahu said: “Everything that is said in the presence of the dead, they know until the grave is sealed.” Rabbi Hiyya bar Abba and Rabbi Shimon son of Rabbi disagreed about this: one said until the grave is sealed, and the other said until the flesh decomposes. In tractate Berakhot, chapter “Mi Shemeto,” there is an extensive discussion about 200R 205R

[A] Or: “The only difference between us and the righteous dead is speech alone” — This alternate translation makes the comparison between the living and dead more explicit by adding ‘dead’ after ‘righteous,’ which is implied but not stated in the original. This clarifies the meaning for readers unfamiliar with the Talmudic context.

[i] This appears to be referring to the biblical sequence found in Leviticus regarding purification rituals, where purification (טהרה) precedes sanctification (קדושה). The author applies this principle to the deceased’s spiritual journey.

[ii] This refers to a story in the Jerusalem Talmud about Rabbi Nahum bar Simai, who was known for his exceptional piety and had never looked at Roman statues or images during his lifetime. When he died, they covered these images out of respect, believing he shouldn’t have to see them in death either.

[iii] This refers to a story in the Talmud (Bava Batra 58a) about a magician who was exhuming corpses. Rabbi Banayah confronted him, demonstrating that the dead retain a certain awareness and dignity that should be respected.

מיניה מערתא דרבי חייא וכו׳. ובחזקת הבתים ברב בנאיה כד מטא למערתא דאברהם ולמערתיה דאדם הראשון:[i]

the dead's knowledge of worldly matters, apart from their perception in the World to Come. Similarly, in Bava Metzia, chapter "HaSokher," regarding Reish Lakish who was marking the graves of rabbis but could not find the cave of Rabbi Hiyya, etc. And in "Hazakat HaBatim" concerning Rav Banayah when he reached the cave of Abraham and the cave of Adam, the first man. 210R

פרק כ״ו

Chapter 26

ולהיות כי הנשמה מכרת בכבוד הגוף וכן בבזיונו אחר מותו[ii] בזה נבין ונדע כי ג״ח לגוף הוא ג״ח ג״כ לנשמה ולכחותיה כל א׳ כפי מקום כבודו ע״י בני אדם החיים שהם בעלי גוף ונשמה טהורה בתוכם ואין לזלזל בכבוד שום מת וכ״ש ת״ח. עוד הזהירו שלא לעשות נישואין בחדר שמת בו ת״ח מחדש והמתים יכולים להזיק למי שמזיק להם.[iii] ואמרו כי המת מגיד בטורח גדול[iv] בנ״ל

Since the soul recognizes the honor of the body and likewise its disgrace after death,[1] we can understand and know that acts of kindness to the body are also acts of kindness to the soul and its faculties,[2] each according to its proper place, performed through living people who possess both body and pure soul within them. One should not dishonor any deceased person, especially a Torah scholar.[3] The Sages further warned against holding wedding celebrations in a room where a Torah scholar has recently died, and the dead can harm those who harm them. They said that the dead communicate only with great difficulty, as mentioned elsewhere, and regarding the 5R 10R

[1]This opening establishes the text's central premise: there is an ongoing relationship between the soul and its physical vessel even after death, which provides theological justification for proper treatment of the deceased.

[2]The author expands the concept of gemilut chasadim (acts of loving-kindness) to include care for the deceased, suggesting that such actions benefit not just the body but the soul itself.

[3]Throughout the text, Torah scholars (talmidei chachamim) are afforded special status even after death, reflecting the belief that their elevated spiritual status continues beyond physical life.

[i]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse on Truthful Speech — This passage appears within the larger discussion of the soul's journey after death. The author is explaining how ritual washing (tahara) affects the deceased's connection to the physical world, suggesting that the purification process begins the soul's transition from worldly consciousness toward spiritual awareness. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Avodah Zarah — The author cites this Talmudic passage to support the idea that the dead maintain awareness of this world. The story about covering statues when Rabbi Nahum died implies that the deceased can still see what happens around them. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Moed Katan — This reference to statues speaking and being covered with mats serves as evidence for the author's argument about the dead's continued awareness of worldly matters. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot — The author mentions this as a source that extensively discusses the dead's knowledge of worldly matters, reinforcing his argument about the deceased's continued awareness. | Cf. Zohar, Section on Soul Garments — The phrase 'garments made of light' (מחלצות מבתנות אור) echoes Zoharic teachings about the soul's spiritual vestments. The author is drawing on kabbalistic concepts of how souls are clothed in different spiritual garments after death.

[ii]This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the soul remains aware of how its body is treated after death, which forms the theological basis for the elaborate care of the deceased in Jewish funeral rituals.

[iii]This reflects the belief that the deceased retain certain powers and awareness, including the ability to cause harm to those who dishonor them—a belief that persisted in Jewish folk practices around death and burial.

[iv]This refers to the concept that the dead can communicate, but only with great difficulty and spiritual effort, which appears in various mystical traditions and particularly in Sefer Hasidim.

במ״א ואמרו על פסוק כי לי
15 תכרע כל ברך תשבע כל לשון
שכשהנשמה נפטרת מן הגוף
הולכת להשתחוות לפני השכינה
מיד ומשבעת אותה שלא תגלה
דבר ממה שרואה באותו עולם
20 אלא ברשות.[i] לכן אין טוב לאדם
רק להיות תמים עם ה׳ ולא
יבקש עתידות כי רוב העוסקים
בזה אחריתם היא נבל כי פעמים
מערבים קדש בחול או כי
25 כופין המדרגות ונהפכים עליהם
לרועץ. ובזוהר פ׳ מקץ דף קנ״ה
ע״ב כתוב כל עובדוהי דעלמא
לאו אינון אלא ברעותא דלבא
וכד סליק ברעותא דבר נש וזהו
30 גם את העולם נתן בלבם ולכן
אין לשלם רעה תחת רעה כי בזה
משלים כח הרע ועובר על לאו
דדברי קבלה אל תאמר אשלמה
רע והמדבר לשון הרע מגביר
35 כח הנחש הקדמוני[ii] וממהרין
ליפרע ממנו בעה״ז. ואמרו בפ׳
משפטים בגין לישנא בישא מרעין
באים לעלמא וגורמים שהנחש
מתפשט מקשקשותיו פן יחריב
40 העולם בהם ועולה לקטרג עיין
פ׳ פקודי בהיכלות ואוי לבעלי
לשון. ומי שאינו משאיל ספריו
לאחרים נמצא כתוב כי בשימות
לא ישארו ביד יורשיו[iii] וטוב
45 להניח ספריו לבן ההוגה בהם
ומשאיל אותם ואמרו עוד כי
אשה שקונה ספרים להשאילן
לאחרים ללמוד בהם זוכה

verse “For to Me every knee shall bend, every tongue shall swear” (Isaiah 45:23), they taught that when 15R
the soul departs from the body, it immediately goes to bow before the Divine Presence, which makes it swear not to reveal anything it sees in that world except with permission.

Therefore, it is best for a person to be whole- 20R
hearted with God and not seek knowledge of future events,[1] for most who engage in such practices ultimately come to ruin, since they sometimes mix the holy with the mundane or force spiritual levels to reveal themselves, which then turn against them de- 25R
structively. In the Zohar (Miketz 155b) it is written: “All the workings of the world depend solely on the intentions of the heart,” and when a person’s intention rises, this fulfills “He has even put eternity into their hearts” (Ecclesiastes 3:11). Therefore, one 30R
should not repay evil with evil, for this completes the power of evil and transgresses the prohibition in Scripture: “Do not say, ‘I will repay evil’” (Proverbs 20:22). One who speaks evil language strengthens the power of the primordial serpent,[2] and divine ret- 35R
ribution hastens to collect from him in this world. They said in Parashat Mishpatim that because of evil speech, diseases come to the world and cause the serpent to spread from its scales, lest it destroy the world with them, and it rises to accuse (see Parashat 40R
Pekudei in the Heikhalot section); woe to those who possess [such] a tongue.

Regarding one who does not lend his books to others, it is written that when he dies, they will not remain in his heirs’ possession. It is good to leave 45R
one’s books to a son who studies them and lends them to others. They further said that a woman who purchases books to lend to others for study mer-

[1] This warning against divination practices appears somewhat unexpectedly in this passage about funeral practices, but connects to the concept that the dead possess knowledge of spiritual realms that the living should not attempt to access improperly.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that human speech has cosmic consequences, with evil speech literally empowering negative spiritual forces represented by the primordial serpent.

[i] This describes the belief that immediately upon death, the soul encounters the Divine Presence and is sworn to secrecy about the spiritual realms it witnesses—a concept that explains why the righteous do not return to reveal heavenly secrets.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that evil speech literally strengthens cosmic evil, represented by the primordial serpent (nachash hakadmoni), creating not just social harm but metaphysical damage.

[iii] This represents a folk belief about divine justice—that one who refuses to share knowledge through lending books will be punished by having those books lost after death. This incentivizes generosity with Torah learning materials.

לבנים ת״ח. ונמצא כתוב שמי
50 שנושא ציצית ותפילין כל היום
בני מעלה יספידו עליו במותו.
ראינו להעלות פה סוד לוית
אורחים וממנה נבין קצת מכוונת
לוית המת. אמרו רבנן כי גדולה
55 מצות הלויה שמצלת האדם מכל
נזק שאירע לו[i] במ״ש חכמינו ז״ל
רבי פלוני אלוייה לרבי פלוני
ארבע אמות במתא ואיתרע ליה
נזקא ואתנציל מיניה. ולכן אין
60 אומרים ללויה חזור. ומצוה זו
חשובה מאד כי בעה״ב בזכות
ג״ח שעושה הקדושה עמו וגורם
לויית הקדושה עם האורח[ii] כי
היא שמירה הדרך ודאי שכל
65 שפע היורד מהת״ת היא שומרת
אותו. ועוד שהוא בפתח כניסת
הדרך כמו שדרשו על פסוק
בזאת יבא אהרן אל הקדש והיינו
אור. ה״א ואות ה״א שבשם
70 רודפת אחר היחוד שלכן היא
חולת אהבה מצד מונעי היחוד.
והיחוד הם יה״ו אותיות הזכר
וטלא דנגיד מניה[iii] והם עם
בעל הבית זה שהוא במקום
75 הת״ת הנקרא לחם. ובן הוא
נותן מלחמו לאורח וזה לויה
יו״ד מימין ה״א משמאל וא״ו
באמצע. ובהיות עושה עמו לויה
גורם שהה״א תלך עמו שהיא

its having sons who are Torah scholars.[1] It is also written that one who wears tzitzit and tefillin all day will be eulogized by heavenly beings at his death. 50R

We have deemed it appropriate to present here the secret of accompanying guests, from which we can understand somewhat the intention behind accompanying the deceased.[2] The Rabbis said that the mitzvah of accompaniment is so great that it saves a person from any harm that might befall him, as our Sages of blessed memory said: "Rabbi So-and-so accompanied Rabbi So-and-so for four cubits in the city, and harm befell him but he was saved from it." Therefore, we do not tell someone who is accompanying another to turn back. This commandment is very important, for through the acts of kindness performed by the host, holiness accompanies him and causes Divine holiness to accompany the guest, serving as protection for the journey, as all divine flow descending from Tiferet guards him. Moreover, this occurs at the threshold of the journey's beginning, as they interpreted the verse "With this shall Aaron enter the holy place" (Leviticus 16:3), meaning "light." The letter hei in the Divine Name pursues unification, which is why it is "love sick" due to those who prevent unification.[3] The unification consists of the letters yod, hei, and vav—the masculine letters—and the dew that flows from them, together with this householder who stands in place of Tiferet, which is called "bread." Thus, he gives of his bread to the guest, and this accompaniment consists of yod on the right, hei on the left, and vav in the middle.[4] When 55R 60R 65R 70R 75R

[1] This unusual statement recognizes women's participation in Torah transmission, albeit indirectly through enabling others' study rather than through direct learning.

[2] The author draws a conceptual parallel between escorting living guests (levayat orchim) and accompanying the dead in funeral processions (levayat ha-met), suggesting both share underlying spiritual principles.

[3] This uses imagery from Song of Songs ("love sick") to personify the letter hei of the divine name YHVH, presenting it as yearning for mystical unification with the other letters, particularly the masculine elements yod-hei-vav.

[4] This describes a mystical arrangement of the divine name's letters that creates a protective structure around the traveler, whether living or deceased.

[i] The mitzvah of accompaniment (levayah) is valued not just for its kindness to the one accompanied but for its protective benefit to the accompanier—a theme that the author will develop in relation to funeral processions as well.

[ii] This presents a mystical interpretation where performing the physical act of accompaniment creates a corresponding spiritual reality—divine holiness literally accompanies both the person performing the kindness and its recipient.

[iii] The author employs a technical kabbalistic concept where the letters yod-hei-vav represent the masculine aspect of divinity that produces 'dew' (divine influence), reflecting Lurianic kabbalistic terminology.

שמירת הדרך וכן האורח יכוין לזה. ועקר תפלת הדרך נוסחה הוא ר״ת לויה לישועתך קויתי ה׳ ל׳ פעמים. ויהי נועם ו׳ פעמים. יהי רצון וכו׳ כדאמרי׳ בגמ׳ וחותם ברוך שומע תפלה. הנה אנכי שולח מלאך וכו׳ עד ולהביאך אל המקום ה׳ פעמים ויש מכניסים תחת יהי רצון במלת לויה יברכך ה׳ וגו׳ או יוהך ישמרני וכו׳ ואומרים ברכות תפלת הדרך לעצמה. וזה טעם עסק התורה בדרך לעשות נייחא לשכינה שעמו לשומרו ועיין בזהר מסוד תפלת הדרך בארוכה. והאדם החי שהוא במדרגת אמת עמו שכינה בכח חלקי נשמתו המיוחדת עם דודה ושכינה רודפת אחר הצדיק ליהנות מהשפעות הת״ת המשפיע על נשמתו בעוסקו בתורה בפרט ובשאר מצות בכלל. ובהלוייתו למת שהוא ודאי אורח הנוטה ללון במקום מנוחתו גורם לשכינה שהיא צדק שתלך לפניו[i] כדכתיב צדק לפניו יהלך בעת שמשים לדרך פעמיו לעלות למקום מנוחתו וכן כתיב והלך לפניך צדקך כי השכינה שנזדווגה עמו ע״י מעשיו כדי להתייחד עם דודה כנזכר עתה היא מקדמתו והולכת לפניו ואומרת לחיצונים סולו סולו

he performs this accompaniment, he causes the hei to go with the guest, serving as protection for the journey, and the guest should intend this as well.[A]

The essence of the Wayfarer's Prayer formula comprises the initial letters of "for Your salvation I wait, O Lord" (Genesis 49:18), recited thirty times. "May the pleasantness" (Psalm 90:17) six times. "May it be Your will..." as stated in the Talmud, concluding with "Blessed are You who hears prayer." "Behold, I send an angel..." (Exodus 23:20) until "to bring you to the place" (23:20) five times. Some insert under "May it be Your will" in the word "accompaniment" (levayah) "May the Lord bless you" etc., or "May He guard me," etc., and recite the blessings of the Wayfarer's Prayer separately. This explains the purpose of studying Torah while traveling: to bring comfort to the Divine Presence that accompanies him for protection. See the Zohar for an extensive discussion of the secret of the Wayfarer's Prayer.

A living person who is at the level of "truth" has the Divine Presence with him through the power of his soul parts united with their Beloved,[B] and the Divine Presence pursues the righteous person to enjoy the influences of Tiferet,[1] which bestows upon his soul when he engages in Torah study specifically and other commandments generally. When accompanying a deceased person, who is certainly a traveler lodging at his resting place, one causes the Divine Presence, which is Righteousness (Tzedek), to go before him, as it is written: "Righteousness shall go before Him" (Psalm 85:14) when he sets his steps on the path to ascend to his resting place. Similarly, it

[A] Or: "By performing the act of accompaniment, he causes the divine letter hei to travel with the guest, which provides spiritual protection for the journey, and the guest should likewise direct his intention toward this mystical process" — This alternate translation more explicitly identifies the 'hei' as a letter of the divine name and emphasizes the importance of kavvanah (directed intention) in activating this mystical protection.

[B] Or: "The living person who has attained the level of Truth has the Divine Presence accompanying him through the power of his soul components that are united with their divine Source" — This alternate translation makes more explicit that 'dodah' (literally 'beloved' or 'uncle') refers to the divine source or origin of the soul parts. It also clarifies that 'emet' (truth) represents a specific spiritual level rather than merely truthfulness.

[1] This describes a reciprocal relationship where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah, associated with the sefirah of Malkhut) seeks connection with the righteous person who embodies the divine attribute of Tiferet through Torah study and mitzvot.

[i] Here the author connects the Divine Presence with the sefirah of Righteousness (Tzedek), associated with Malkhut, which creates a protective vanguard for the soul during its journey after death.

פנו דרך הרימו מכשול[i] ופנו
מקום לדיוקן עליון ועוד כי עתה
מתעצם כח עוש״י דבר״ו של
מקום בעה״ז להאיר לארץ חפץ
ולדרים עליה מעין מה שפעל
ועשה בעה״ז בהיותו משתעשע
עם קוב״ה ושכינתיה בתוך חדרי
ג״ע כאשר יבא לפנינו בחלק
ג׳ בעה״י ואם יצוייר באפשר
שיהיו בהלויית המת ששים רבוא
דיוקני נשמות[ii] ודאי כי יוסיפו
עילוי לנפטר כי כינוס האורות
יהלו עליו באורם והתורה
שהיא סם חיים לו להפארת
ומתפשטת למעלה בסוד נוף
האילן לכל הדיוקנאות על כן
אמרו כנתינתה כך נטילתה
ועוד נדבר מסוד הלויה לפנינו
בס״ד ועיין במגילה פרק בני
העיר ובכתובות פרק האשה
שנתארמלה וגם בברכות פרק
מי שמתו מחיוב לוית המת ושכר
מצוה זו:[iii]

is written: "Your righteousness shall go before you" (Isaiah 58:8), for the Divine Presence that joined with him through his deeds in order to unite with her Beloved, as mentioned, now precedes him and goes before him, saying to the external forces: "Clear the way, clear the way, prepare the road! Remove the obstacles[1] and make room for the supernal image!" Furthermore, now the power of "those who do His word" intensifies in this world to illuminate the desirable land and those who dwell upon it, similar to what he accomplished and did in this world when he delighted with the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence within the chambers of the Garden of Eden, as will be presented before us in Part Three, God willing. 115R 120R 125R

If it were possible to have sixty thousand soul-images in the funeral procession,[2] they would certainly add elevation to the deceased, for the gathering of lights would illuminate him with their radiance, and the Torah, which is the elixir of life for him, adorns and extends upward in the secret of the tree's foliage to all the image[A]s. Therefore, they said: "As it was given, so it is taken." We will 130R 135R

[A] Or: "for the congregation of spiritual lights would shine upon him with their radiance, and the Torah, which serves as an elixir of life for him, glorifies and extends upward according to the mystical principle of the tree's canopy reaching all the divine configurations" — This alternate translation clarifies that 'lights' refers to spiritual illuminations, not physical light. It also better conveys that 'nof ha-ilan' (tree canopy) is being used as a kabbalistic metaphor for how Torah influence extends upward through multiple spiritual levels, and that 'diyoknaot' refers to divine configurations or formations, not merely images.

[1] This adapts Isaiah 57:14, reimagining it as the Divine Presence commanding negative spiritual forces to make way for the soul's journey after death.

[2] The number 600,000 (shishim ribbo) has special significance in Jewish mystical tradition, representing the complete assembly of Israel's souls. Here it suggests an ideal funeral attended by representatives of the entire spiritual community.

[i] This adapts Isaiah 57:14 into a mystical context, depicting the Divine Presence commanding negative forces (chitzonim) to clear a path for the ascending soul, transforming biblical language into a description of the soul's posthumous journey.

[ii] The number 600,000 (shishim ribbo) has special significance in Jewish tradition as the number of Israelite males who left Egypt and the number of letters in the Torah. Here it represents an ideal number of soul-images accompanying the deceased.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section on Visiting the Sick — The text makes reference to earlier discussions on acts of kindness (gemilut chasadim) related to care for the sick, connecting it with the present discussion of caring for the deceased as a continuation of the same spiritual principle. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Miketz 155b — The author directly quotes this Zoharic passage to establish the importance of proper intention in all actions, particularly those related to death and funeral rites. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Mishpatim — The text references Zoharic teachings about the metaphysical consequences of evil speech, showing how improper speech can create harmful spiritual effects. | Cf. Isaiah 45:23—"For to Me every knee shall bend, every tongue shall swear" — This biblical verse is interpreted mystically to describe the soul's journey immediately after death, when it must bow before the Divine Presence and take an oath. | Cf. Leviticus 16:3—"With this shall Aaron enter

discuss more about the secret of accompaniment later, God willing. See Megillah chapter "The People of the City," Ketubot chapter "The Woman Who Was Widowed," and Berakhot chapter "One Whose Dead" regarding the obligation of accompanying the deceased and the reward for this commandment. 140R

פרק כ״ז

Chapter 27

סוד קבורת מתים הוא נחת רוח לנשמה וכל זמן דגופא לא נחית בדוכתא אף רוחא הכי הוא. ונקרא חסד של אמת וכן כל מה שעושים עם המתים כי האדם בחייו קרוי אדם דהיינו אמת[i] ויש בעשור אמת מ״ה כדאיתא בתקונים ואמת הוא יחוד ת״ת ומלכות כדאיתא בזהר בעובדא דינוקא דהיינו א׳ א״ס ובהסתלק הבינה א׳ מאמת ויתעלם הת״ת מהמלכות והיינו שיעשה מת[ii] דהיינו מוצנע ומתעלם וישלוט למטה המיתה רגליה יורדות מות. והטעם כי בינה משפעת חיים ובהנטל החיים כתיב הן אני עץ יבש. ונפרד

The secret of burying the dead is to provide comfort to the soul,[1] for as long as the body does not rest in its place, neither does the spirit. This is called "true kindness"[A] (chesed shel emet), as is everything done for the dead. For a person during their lifetime is called "adam," which signifies "emet" (truth), and within the word "emet" is found the divine name M"H (45),[2] as explained in the Tikkunim. "Emet" represents the unification of Tiferet and Malkhut, as explained in the Zohar in the story of the child, where alef represents Ein Sof (the Infinite). When Binah (represented by the letter alef) withdraws from "emet," Tiferet becomes concealed from Malkhut, resulting in "met" (death)—meaning hidden and concealed[3]—and death rules below, as it is written, "her feet descend to death." 5R 10R 15R

The reason is that Binah flows with life, and when

[A] Or: "kindness of truth" — A more literal translation of 'chesed shel emet' would be 'kindness of truth,' which emphasizes that this form of kindness embodies ultimate truth and cannot be reciprocated. While 'true kindness' is more elegant in English, the literal translation preserves the connection to 'emet' (truth) that is central to the passage's wordplay.

[1] The original Hebrew phrase 'nachat ruach laneshama' implies not just comfort but spiritual satisfaction or rest, indicating that proper burial fulfills a metaphysical need for the soul.

[2] This refers to gematria (Jewish numerology), where the Hebrew letters of 'emet' (אמת) have a combined numerical value that relates to the divine name M"H (מה), which equals 45. This numerical connection reveals the divine essence within truth.

[3] The Hebrew 'mutzna umit'alem' more precisely conveys that death makes something both 'stored away' and 'disappeared from view,' emphasizing both physical burial and metaphysical concealment.

the holy place" — The text reinterprets this verse about the High Priest's Temple service as a mystical reference to the beginning of a spiritual journey, connecting ritual accompaniment with divine protection. | Cf. Genesis 49:18—"For Your salvation I wait, O Lord" — This verse forms the basis for a kabbalistic prayer formula used in the Wayfarer's Prayer, which is connected to the mystical practice of accompaniment both for the living and the deceased. | Cf. Psalm 85:14—"Righteousness shall go before Him" — This verse is reinterpreted in a funeral context to suggest that the Divine Presence (associated with the sefirah of Righteousness/Tzedek) accompanies the deceased soul on its journey.

[i] The author is making a wordplay connecting 'adam' (human) with 'emet' (truth), suggesting that the living human embodies divine truth through the unification of higher spiritual realms.

[ii] Here the text presents a profound kabbalistic wordplay: when the letter alef (representing Binah/divine understanding) is removed from the word 'emet' (truth), what remains is 'met' (dead). This illustrates how death represents the separation of higher divine attributes from lower ones.

מן הארץ התחתונה והאדם
הוא חי מקיים היחוד וקושר
נשמה מהבינה. ברוח מהת״ת.
בנפש מהמלכות.[i] ומטהר הגוף
מן הטומאות שלא ישלטו בו
החצונים כשמת הפריד היחודים
האלה שלש מדות אלו שהם בינה
ת״ת ומלכות. וכל זמן שלא נקבר
אין הנשמה עולה כלל ולכן
תקונו להתעסק בצרכי קבורתו
כדכתיב כי עפר אתה וגו׳ דהיינו
הכל היה מן העפר ואפי׳ גלגל
חמה כי מן העפר מוצא הכל וכל
טבין וטיבו דעלמא מיניה נפקין
ולכן הדל דלית ליה מגרמיה
כלום[ii] אמר הכתוב מקימי מעפר
דל כי נפיק מההוא עפרא ובג״ד
הוא דל ברם אבק לא עביד
פירי וכן אפר על כן כתיב
ברשעים כי יהיו אפר תחת כפות
רגליכם[iii] ועפר איהו כללא
דעילא ותתא והוא בבינה ועקרו
במלכות ומצד כחות הדין פ׳
נשא ובלק ועוד שהיא יסוד העפר
שכל ג׳ יסודות אחרים מראים
פעולותיהם בה. והיא עושה
פירות בעפר. ולכן המת ניתן
לקבורה דהיינו עפר מלמטה
ה״א תחתה ועפר מלמעלה
ה״א עילאה ואדם וא״ו באמצע
אוחז בשני הה״ן[iv] והיינו

life is taken away, it is written, "Behold, I am a dry tree." The person becomes separated from the lower earth. A living person maintains the divine unification, binding the neshamah from Binah, the ruach from Tiferet, and the nefesh from Malkhut, and purifies the body from impurities so that external forces cannot dominate it. When one dies, these unifications of the three attributes—Binah, Tiferet, and Malkhut—are separated. As long as the body is not buried, the soul cannot ascend at all.[A] Therefore, the proper correction is to attend to burial needs, as it is written, "For you are dust, etc.," meaning everything comes from dust, even the sun's orb, for everything originates from dust, and all worldly goodness emerges from it.

Therefore, regarding the poor person who has nothing of his own, Scripture states, "He raises the poor from the dust," for he emerges from that dust,[1] and therefore he is poor. However, powder does not produce fruit, nor does ash, which is why it is written concerning the wicked, "They shall be ashes under the soles of your feet." Dust encompasses both upper and lower realms; it is in Binah and has its root in Malkhut, and is related to the forces of judgment, as discussed in Parashat Naso and Balak. Furthermore, it is the foundation of earth, in which the other three elements display their effects, and it produces fruit like dust.

Therefore, the dead are given to burial—dust below (the lower hei), dust above (the upper hei), and the person (vav) in the middle,[B] holding

[A] Or: "And as long as the body is not buried, the soul cannot ascend whatsoever" — This alternate translation emphasizes the absolute nature of the statement with 'whatsoever' (matching the Hebrew 'klal'), underscoring the critical importance of burial for the soul's journey. The original translation is accurate but slightly softens the emphatic nature of the original.

[B] Or: "meaning dust below corresponding to the lower hei, dust above corresponding to the

[1] The Hebrew uses the phrase 'nafik mehahu afra' which more precisely means 'emerges from that dust,' suggesting both physical and spiritual origination rather than just return.

[i] This passage outlines the kabbalistic understanding of how the three levels of soul (neshamah, ruach, nefesh) connect to three divine attributes (Binah, Tiferet, Malkhut), revealing how human consciousness bridges multiple spiritual realms.

[ii] The author creatively interprets the biblical verse about raising the poor from dust, suggesting that poverty itself emerges from dust, paralleling how humans come from and return to dust, thus linking social status with cosmic cycles.

[iii] The text distinguishes between dust (which is productive and life-giving) and ash (which is sterile and represents complete destruction), using this to explain the different cosmic fates of the righteous versus the wicked.

[iv] This describes the mystical symbolism of burial, where the body (represented by the letter vav) is placed between dust below and dust above (represented by the two hei letters of the divine name), creating a complete divine name that facilitates the soul's ascension.

דמהדרינן א׳ לגבי מת ואהדר
50 אמת ואנו גורמים שתעלה הנשמה
למעלה למעלה בכוונת הקבורה
ובמעשה ובעלייתה מייחד וקושר
סוד אמת שהוא היחוד עליון
והיינו חסד של אמת. [i]

both heis. This is why we return the alef to the dead, restoring "emet." Through our intention and action in burial, we cause the soul to ascend higher and higher, and in its ascension, it unifies and binds the secret of "emet,"[1] which is the supernal unification—and this is the meaning of "true kindness." 50R 55R

55 ועקר הסוד הזה בעפר ארץ
ישראל [ii] כי בה הוא סוד העפר
דוקא ולזה אמר יעקב ועשית
עמדי חסד של אמת אל נא
תקברני במצרים. ואמרו
60 שהקבור בא״י כאלו קבור תחת
המזבח כי מקדש מול מקדש
ומזבח מול מזבח וכבר נודע מה
הוא מזבח של מעלה א״כ הקבור
בא״י הוא קבור תחת קו השוה
65 ונשאר בתוך כמו המרכז באמצע
הגלגל [iii] והשקד שממנו יתהוה

The essence of this mystery lies specifically in the soil of the Land of Israel,[2] for in it resides the true secret of earth. This is why Jacob said, "Show me true kindness; please do not bury me in Egypt." They said that one who is buried in the Land of Israel is as if buried beneath the altar, for sanctuary corresponds to sanctuary and altar to altar. It is already known what the heavenly altar represents; therefore, one buried in the Land of Israel is buried beneath the alignment of cosmic forces[A] and remains within, like the center point in the middle of a circle.[3] The almond-shaped essence from which 60R 65R

upper hei, and the human as vav in between" — This alternate translation more explicitly shows the correspondence between burial elements and Hebrew letters of the divine name, which is central to the kabbalistic meaning. It clarifies that the human body itself is symbolically the letter vav connecting upper and lower realms.

[A] Or: "beneath the celestial equator" — The term 'kav hashaveh' could be interpreted more cosmologically as the celestial equator, the imaginary line dividing the heavens. This would emphasize the author's use of astronomical imagery, though it might lose some of the mystical nuance of the original.

[1] The original text uses active language suggesting that human burial practices actively cause cosmic unifications in higher spiritual realms, emphasizing the power of proper ritual to affect metaphysical reality.

[2] The author is continuing a discussion about the mystical significance of burial and how the physical location and elements involved have profound spiritual effects. This passage particularly focuses on the special qualities of burial in the Land of Israel.

[3] This cosmological metaphor reflects the kabbalistic understanding of the Land of Israel as the

[i] Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The passage references the Tikkunei Zohar regarding the numerical value of M"H (45) within the word 'emet' (truth), connecting human existence to divine emanations. | Cf. Zohar — The text cites the Zohar's explanation of how 'emet' (truth) represents the unification of the divine attributes Tiferet and Malkhut, which is a fundamental kabbalistic concept. | Cf. Isaiah 56:3 — The phrase 'Behold, I am a dry tree' is quoted to illustrate the spiritual death that occurs when divine life force is withdrawn. | Cf. Malachi 3:21 — The verse about the wicked becoming 'ashes under the soles of your feet' is used to contrast the productive nature of dust with the sterility of ashes, symbolizing spiritual potentiality versus destruction. | Cf. Psalm 113:7 — The verse 'He raises the poor from the dust' is interpreted kabbalisticall to explain how humans emerge from the element of dust, connecting physical creation with spiritual status. | Cf. Genesis 3:19 — The verse 'For you are dust, and to dust you shall return' is referenced to explain the metaphysical necessity of burial as returning to one's elemental source.

[ii] The author establishes that there is a special mystical quality to the soil of the Land of Israel that makes it particularly important for burial. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that physical elements from sacred places contain spiritual properties.

[iii] This uses the cosmological metaphor of a circle with its center point to describe the spiritual position of someone buried in the Land of Israel—they are at the cosmic center, the point of balance and harmony in the spiritual realms.

האדם[i] כנזכר למעלה נשאר
שם לעולם. ונשאתני ממצרים.
וכן כתוב בתקון כ״א דף נ״ז
וצדיקים שהם דגים הגדלים על
מי התורה[ii] נאמר בהם אסיפתם
לעמיהם זהו מיתתן וכנפי מצוה
מכסין על דמן[iii] שאין שולט
בהם מלאכי חבלה שהן כלבים
חצופים בסוד כסוי הדם והדם
הוא הנפש ועפר שמכסים עליו
הוא בסוד וכפר אדמתו עמו
וקבורה משום כפרה והספד
יקרא דחיי ושכבי כדאי׳ בפ׳
נגמר הדין וה״ה ללויה. ועב״ז
אפי׳ בח״ל תועיל ודאי הכוונה.
ולכן כל אחד מהקהל משתדל
לשום עפר עליו לסייע ליחוד
ולהריק עליו משפע הבינה
ולהסתירו בכנפיה. דלא דחילת
מינץ הטורף וישליכו עליו העפר
ג״פ[iv] נגד בחינתה המקבלת
ובחינת עצמה ובחינת השפעתה
או להגן על נפשו רוחו ונשמתו
ועוד שממנה מוצא קו החסד וקו
הדין וקו הרחמים ומים אש ורוח
מראים פעולתם ביסוד העפר

a person is formed,[A] as mentioned above, remains there forever. "Carry me out of Egypt." This is also written in Tikkun 21, page 57: "Regarding the 70R
righteous, who are like fish growing in the waters of Torah, it is said that they are 'gathered to their people'—this refers to their death. The wings of a commandment cover their blood,[1] as the angels of destruction, which are like impudent dogs, have 75R
no power over them, in the mystery of covering the blood. And blood represents the soul, while the earth that covers it corresponds to 'He will atone for His land and His people.' Burial is for the purpose of atonement, and the eulogy honors both the living 80R
and the dead, as stated in the chapter 'The Verdict is Concluded,' and the same applies to the funeral procession.

Nevertheless, even outside the Land of Israel, proper intention certainly has efficacy. Therefore, 85R
each member of the community strives to place earth upon the deceased to assist in the unification and to pour upon him from the abundance of Binah[2] (Divine Understanding) and to conceal him beneath her wings, so that he need not fear the 90R
predatory hawk. They cast earth upon him three times,[3] corresponding to her receptive aspect, her essence, and her influence—or to protect his nefesh,

[A] Or: "The luz bone from which a person will be regenerated" — The term 'shaked' (almond) is a reference to the luz bone, which in rabbinic tradition is believed to be indestructible and the seed from which the body will be regenerated at resurrection. This more explicit translation might be clearer for readers unfamiliar with this mystical concept.

spiritual center of the world. One buried there is positioned at the central point of cosmic forces, an ideal location for the soul's journey and eventual resurrection.

[1] This metaphorical language connects several concepts: the biblical commandment to cover blood after slaughter, the protection that performing mitzvot provides, and the image of divine sheltering wings (such as in Psalms 91:4). The image suggests that righteous deeds create a spiritual protection that remains after death.

[2] Binah (Understanding) is the third of the divine sefirot (emanations) in Kabbalah, associated with the divine feminine and with mercy. The text suggests that burial rituals can channel this divine attribute to benefit the deceased.

[3] The threefold pattern appears frequently in Jewish ritual and has multiple symbolic meanings.

[i] The term "שקד" (shaked/almond) refers to the luz bone, believed in Jewish tradition to be the indestructible nucleus from which the body will be reconstituted at resurrection.

[ii] This metaphor compares righteous individuals to fish and Torah to water, suggesting that just as fish can only survive in water, the righteous derive their spiritual sustenance and life from immersion in Torah.

[iii] This phrase uses the biblical commandment to cover blood (Leviticus 17:13) as a metaphor for how the performance of commandments provides spiritual protection for the deceased.

[iv] The threefold casting of earth corresponds to kabbalistic structures, particularly the three aspects of Binah (Understanding) mentioned immediately after: its receptive quality, its essence, and its influence. This also parallels the three primary components of the soul: nefesh, ruach, and neshamah.

הקדוש והוא מחפה על גופו
ומגין עליו כמו שחלקי נשמתו
מתכנסים למעלה בעפר עליון
אל נרתקם אם זכו בדכתיב
הכל שב אל העפר ויש נוהגים
בהשלכת העפר חמשה פעמים
ומכוונים למתק גם חלק חיה
ויחידה. ולמיתוק חמש גבורות
מנצפ״ך[i] עליו. ומה שיש להם
לומר יבא לפנינו בחלק שפתי
רננות בעה״י. ונוהגים שלא
להושיט אדם לחבירו כלי שבו
משליכין העפר[ii] בו אלא מניחין
אותו לפניו לארץ אולי זה יהיה
על דרך כי אין שלטון ביום
המות ועוד שלא להושיט צרה
ליד חבירו על דרך שאמרו
במועד קטן אי בדידך הוה וכו׳
והוה כשגגה היוצאת מלפני
השליט[iii] וכו׳. ואם בדבור כך
כ״ש המעשה בעידן ריתחא ובעת
פתיחת פה האדמה דאתיהיב
רשותא ח״ו ובפרט לאותם
שנוהגים שהקרובים הם תחלה
לגמול חסד זה עם הנפטר
להמתיק עליו סוד עפר עליון
ולכסותו בסתר כנפיו כנזכר
שלהם יאתה תחלה כי המתחיל

ruach, and neshamah (vital soul, spirit, and higher soul). Additionally, from her emanate the line of loving-kindness, the line of judgment, and the line of mercy; and water, fire, and air demonstrate their effects within the foundation of the sacred earth. It covers his body and protects it, just as the components of his soul gather above in the supernal earth, into their sheath, if they merit it, as it is written, "All returns to the dust."

Some have the custom of casting earth five times, intending to sweeten also the aspects of chayah and yechidah[1] (the two highest soul levels), and to sweeten the five powers of judgment (represented by the letters MaNTzePaKh)[2] upon him. What they should say will be presented before us in the section "Lips of Joyous Song," God willing.

It is customary not to hand directly to another person the vessel with which earth is cast, but rather to place it on the ground before him. Perhaps this follows the principle that "there is no dominion on the day of death," and also to avoid passing distress to one's fellow, as they said in Tractate Mo'ed Katan, "If it were happening to you..." and "like an error proceeding from the ruler."[3] If this applies to speech, how much more so to action, especially at a time of divine anger[A] and when the earth's mouth is opened, when permission is granted, God forbid. This is particularly relevant for those who follow the

[A] Or: "during a period when divine judgment is intensified" — The term 'idan ritcha' is a technical kabbalistic term referring to times when divine judgment is particularly potent and potentially dangerous. This expanded translation captures the concept more precisely.

Here it connects to the three aspects of Binah and the three primary soul components (nefesh, ruach, neshamah), creating a comprehensive spiritual protection.

[1] These are the two highest of the five soul levels in Kabbalah, rarely mentioned in earlier texts but prominent in later mystical teachings. Their inclusion brings the total to five soul levels, corresponding to the five letters of MaNTzePaKh mentioned immediately after.

[2] In Kabbalah, the five Hebrew letters that change form at the end of words (מ-ם, נ-ן, צ-ץ, פ-ף, כ-ך) represent divine judgments that need to be "sweetened" or transformed into mercy. Burial rituals aim to accomplish this transformation for the deceased.

[3] This quotes Ecclesiastes 10:5, applying it to the sensitive moment of burial when careless actions might have unintended negative consequences in both human and spiritual realms.

[i] The letters מנצפ״ך (MaNTzePaKh) are the five Hebrew letters that take a different form when appearing at the end of a word. In Kabbalah, they represent the five aspects of divine judgment (gevurot) that need to be "sweetened" or transformed from severity to mercy.

[ii] This custom reflects the general principle in Jewish mourning practices of not passing items directly between people during rituals associated with death, to avoid symbolically passing or extending mortality.

[iii] This is an allusion to Ecclesiastes 10:5, "There is an evil I have seen under the sun, like an error proceeding from the ruler." The author applies this to the potentially harmful impact of careless speech or actions during sensitive ritual moments.

לא יושג והם פותחים שבילי הנעימות העליון עליו ובפרט בן על אביו. ואם יהיה לו מעפר ארץ ישראל לשום תחתיו
125 ובברית המעור[i] וקצת על עיניו וכפיו עם הכוונה הנזכרת יעשו התקון יותר בשלמות בסוד כי רצו עבדיך את אבניה ואת עפרה יחננו. ורבי פלוני [אבא] שהיה
130 מנשק כיפי דעכו[ii] היה להדבק רוחניותו ברוחניות השורה בעפר הקדוש מארץ הנבחרת אשר עיני ה׳ אלהינו בה. ואנחנו הנבראים מאותו עפר מחוייבים
135 להביאו אל מקום חציבותו שהוא קדוש ונייחא קצת ליושבי חוצה לארץ הוא דמשנה שלימה שנינו כי עפר הארץ שיצא חוצה לארץ דינו כעפר ארץ ישראל[iii] וכן
140 עפר ח״ל שנכנס לארץ דינו כארץ. ואמרו בזהר פ׳ ויחי כי ארץ כנען ומצרים מכלים הגוף בזמן קרוב יותר משאר הארצות.[iv]

custom that relatives should be the first to perform this act of kindness for the departed, sweetening the mystery of supernal earth upon him[A] and covering him in the shelter of His wings, as mentioned. It is 125R
fitting that they go first, for "one who begins cannot be overtaken," and they open the pathways of supernal pleasantness upon him, especially a son for his father.

If one has soil from the Land of Israel to place be- 130R
neath him, at the covenant of the loins,[1] and a little on his eyes and hands, with the intention mentioned, they will perform the rectification more completely, in the mystery of "For Your servants take pleasure in her stones and favor her dust." Rabbi [so-and-so] 135R
who used to kiss the stones of Acre[2] did so to connect his spirituality with the spirituality that dwells in the holy soil of the chosen land, upon which the eyes of the LORD our God are always focused. And we who were created from that soil are obligated to bring it 140R
to its place of origin, which is holy.

There is some comfort for those dwelling outside the Land in that we learned in a complete Mishnah that soil of the Land that has left the Land of Israel retains the status of the soil of the Land 145R

[A] Or: "transforming the harsh judgments associated with the mystery of supernal earth that affect him" — The term 'להמתיק' (to sweeten) in kabbalistic terminology specifically refers to transforming divine judgment (din) into mercy (rachamim). This more expanded translation conveys the technical meaning better, though at the cost of brevity.

[1] This euphemistically refers to the genital area, considered sacred as the site of the covenant of circumcision and procreation. Placing holy soil there has special significance for resurrection and spiritual continuity.

[2] This references a famous story about Rabbi Abba (Ketubot 112a) who would kiss the stones when arriving in the Land of Israel out of his great love for the Holy Land. The text replaces his name with a placeholder, which I've maintained in the translation.

[i] The term "ברית המעור" refers to the genital area, considered a sacred covenant zone. Placing soil from the Land of Israel there has special significance due to its connection to procreation and the continuation of life.

[ii] This refers to Rabbi Abba's practice (Ketubot 112a) of kissing the stones of Acre (a city in Israel) out of love for the Holy Land. The original text mentions "Rabbi So-and-so" but likely refers to this famous Talmudic account.

[iii] This refers to the halakhic principle that soil from the Land of Israel retains its sacred status even when removed from the Land, and conversely, soil brought into the Land acquires sanctity. This appears in Oholot 17:5 regarding laws of ritual purity.

[iv] Cf. Genesis 47:29-30 — The author uses Jacob's request for burial in the Land of Israel as the primary biblical basis for the spiritual significance of burial location. This reference establishes that even biblical patriarchs recognized the mystical importance of being buried in sacred soil. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 21 — This reference compares the righteous to fish swimming in Torah waters, suggesting that just as fish are protected in their element, the righteous find protection through their immersion in Torah study. The covering of blood refers to the spiritual protection that mitzvot provide for the deceased. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:43 — The author connects burial in earth to this verse about divine atonement, suggesting that the physical act of covering a body with

of Israel,[1] and likewise, soil from outside the Land that enters the Land acquires the status of the Land. They said in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, that the lands of Canaan and Egypt consume the body in less time than other lands. 150R

ואולי זה למצרים להיותה מצרנית לקדושה. וכן הקליפה הקרובה לקדושה הנקרא נגה מקבלת מיתוק בכח שם מילוי ההי״ן בגימטרי״א ב״ן שבשבינה[i] ומטטרו״ן נוטל אותו המלוי אות אחת לכל חמשה ימי השבוע[ii] למתק קליפה זו.[iii] ואחר זה בכח המתק עולה להכלל בקדושה על דרך זה בארץ מצרים. והיינו דכתיב ברוך עמי מצרים.[iv] והועד לי מפי הראיה שעפר א״י מכלה בשר הגוף בזמן חדש ימים כי

This is perhaps true of Egypt because it borders holiness. Similarly, the kelipah (shell/husk) closest to holiness, called Nogah, receives sweetening[A] through the power of the Divine Name spelled with heis (YHVH with the letter hei fully spelled out), which has the numerical value of 52 (corresponding to the divine name BaN) that resides in the Shekhinah. Metatron takes one letter of this spelling for each of the five weekdays to sweeten this kelipah. After this sweetening process, it can be included in holiness,[2] and this is how it works in the land of Egypt. This is the meaning of the verse "Blessed be Egypt My people" (Isaiah 19:25). 155R 160R

I was informed by eyewitness testimony that the

[A] Or: "the shell of impurity nearest to holiness, known as Nogah, undergoes transformation" — This alternative avoids the technical term 'kelipah' in favor of the more descriptive 'shell of impurity,' and replaces the metaphorical 'sweetening' with 'transformation,' which might be clearer to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[1] This halakhic principle from Mishnah Oholot 17:5 is applied mystically here. Just as soil maintains its legal status despite geographic movement, the spiritual qualities associated with the Land of Israel can be transferred through physical elements taken from it.

[2] The process described here reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'birur' (clarification/refinement), where elements from the realm of impurity can be elevated and reclaimed for holiness through specific spiritual processes.

earth parallels the spiritual act of God covering sins with forgiveness. | Cf. Sanhedrin 47a — The reference to this Talmudic chapter establishes the halakhic basis for the mystical interpretations that follow, showing how the author integrates legal and mystical dimensions of Jewish burial practices. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — This reference adds practical information about bodily decomposition rates in different lands, which the author interprets mystically to suggest that holy lands purify the body more quickly by removing physical impurity. | Cf. Psalms 102:15 — This verse is used to explain the mystical practice of using soil from the Land of Israel in burial, suggesting that even the physical elements of the Holy Land contain spiritual potency that can benefit the deceased.

[i] This refers to one of the four kabbalistic spellings of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), where the letter hei is spelled out fully (הה) in both instances, giving a total numerical value of 52, which corresponds to the divine name BaN (בן).

[ii] Metatron is a principal angel in Jewish mysticism who serves as God's representative. The text describes a mystical process where Metatron distributes the spiritual power of the divine name across the weekdays to transform negative forces into positive ones.

[iii] In Kabbalah, 'kelipot' (shells or husks) are negative spiritual forces that conceal holiness. Nogah is unique among these forces because it contains a mixture of good and evil, making it capable of being 'sweetened' or elevated into holiness through proper spiritual work.

[iv] This is a quote from Isaiah 19:25. In its biblical context, it refers to a future time when Egypt, traditionally seen as Israel's oppressor, will be blessed by God. The author uses this verse to illustrate how elements outside of holiness can eventually be incorporated into the realm of holiness.

הבשר להיותו מעור הנחש[i] הוא
מכלה אותו במהרה להסיר
טומאתו ממנה למען יהיה העם
היושב בה נשוא עון ואולי
נטבע בה שתכלה כשיעור זה
ולא פחות ויהיה על פי מה
שנאמר בפ׳ ויקהל דף קצ״ט
ע״ב שכל תלתין יומין אתדנו
גופא ונפשא כחדא[ii] ובג״כ
אשתכחת נשמתא לתתא בארעא
כאתתא דיתבא לבר כל יומי
מסאבותה[iii] לבתר נשמתא סלקא
ולבן תלתין יומין אינון לגיהוץ
ולתספורת כדאמרן. ושם פי׳
ז׳ דיני דיחלפון עליה דבר נש.
עוד שם בדף רי״א סוד רחיצת
הנפשות בנהר דינור ופעם אחרת
עוברת באש כשמעלין אותה
לג״ע עליון שלפי מעלת עלייתה
צריך טבילה אחרת כדאמרן
טבל לקל לא טבל לחמור[iv] ושם
ביאר נשמות העולות בכל
שבת ור״ח למקום הנקרא חומות
ירושלים. ועיין בר״מ פ׳ קדושים
דף פ״ג עפר שנברא ממנו גוף
אדם הראשון כיון דאזעיר גרמיה
אצטריך לגופא אחרא במשכא

soil of the Land of Israel consumes the flesh of the body within a month's time.[A] Since the flesh comes from the skin of the serpent, it quickly consumes it to remove its impurity, so that the people dwelling there might have their iniquity forgiven. Perhaps it is naturally designed to consume at this rate, no less, according to what is written in Parashat Vayakhel (Zohar 199b): "For thirty days the body and soul are judged together, and therefore the soul remains below in the earth like a woman who sits apart during her days of impurity. Afterwards, the soul ascends." This is why the thirty days are designated for the prohibition of laundered garments and haircuts,[1] as we have stated.

There it also explains the seven judgments that pass over a person. Furthermore, on page 211, it reveals the secret of souls being washed in the River of Dinur (River of Fire), and how they pass through fire a second time when elevated to the upper Garden of Eden. According to the level of ascent, another immersion is required, as we have said: "One who has immersed for a minor matter has not immersed for a more serious matter." It also explains how souls ascend every Sabbath and New Moon[2] to a place called "the walls of Jerusalem."

See also Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Kedoshim (83), regarding the dust from which Adam's body

[A] Or: "It was testified to me from direct observation that the soil of the Land of Israel decomposes the body's flesh within a period of one month" — This alternate translation emphasizes the empirical nature of the claim by using terms like 'testified' and 'direct observation' rather than 'informed' and 'eyewitness testimony.' It also uses 'decomposes' instead of 'consumes' for a more scientifically neutral description of the process.

[1] This refers to the Jewish mourning custom called 'sheloshim' (thirty days), during which mourners refrain from cutting hair and wearing freshly laundered clothes. The text provides the mystical basis for this timeframe.

[2] This mystical concept explains why memorial prayers for the deceased (Yizkor) are traditionally recited on holidays. The text suggests these are times when souls experience elevation, making them opportune moments for prayer on their behalf.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that human flesh is spiritually connected to the primordial serpent (nachash) from the Garden of Eden, representing physicality and material desires that must be purified.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase states that 'for thirty days, the body and soul are judged together.' This kabbalistic concept explains why mourning practices extend for thirty days, reflecting the spiritual reality that the soul maintains a connection to the body during this period.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase compares the soul's state after death to 'a woman who sits apart during her days of impurity,' referring to the niddah separation practice. This metaphor suggests a temporary state of separation before purification and reintegration.

[iv] This is a Talmudic principle meaning 'one who has immersed for a minor matter has not immersed for a more serious matter.' The author applies this principle to the soul's purification process, suggesting that higher spiritual levels require more intensive purification.

ובשרא וכתוב בפ׳ תרומה דף ק״מ מאן דנשמתיה נפקת בארעא קדישא אי אתקבר בההוא יומא לא שלטא עליה רוחא מסאבא כלל. וכתוב בזהר אדם ביקר בל ילין אדם דהוא יקר מכל יקרא בל ילין. מ״ט משום דאי יעבדון הכי נמשל כבהמות נדמו מה בעירי לא אתחזי בהו רוח הקדש אוף הכי כבעירי גופא בלא רוח. ואסור לראות צורה עליונה בלא חיות ואסור לבזותו אחר מותו דהא חזינן במועד קטן במעשה דרבה בר בר חנה ורב המנונא שהיו מכבדין זה את זה. וכחות הטומאה תאבים להתלבש בגוף העשוי בצלם של מעלה וכשימות האדם מיתה משונה בר מינן יכאב יותר לצלמו ובפרט הנתלה כי שם מתחברים כחות הטומאה יותר ממתים אחרים. ואולי להיותו תלוי ברוח יסוד שבו הרבה רוחות רעות ולזה צוה לא תלין נבלתו על העץ וקללת אלהים שרוי במקום התלוי[i] שהאויר נפסד וזה טעם הרחקת האדם מן הצואה ודומה לה. ובזהר דף קע״ו אמר כי טוב להקבר בקרקע ואפי׳ לרשע ויש שמשימין סיד תוך הקבר ומנהג יפה הוא שממחה ושופך טומאת הנחש. ועיין בדף קמ״א מישראלים הנפטרים בארץ ובחוצה לארץ ואמר כי הנפטר חוצה לארץ רוח הטומאה שורה

was created: since he diminished himself, he required another body with skin and flesh. In Parashat Terumah (140) it states: "One whose soul departs in the Holy Land, if he is buried on that same day, no spirit of impurity has any power over him at all."

It is written in the Zohar: "A man who is precious does not remain overnight" (Psalms 49:13)—a man who is more precious than anything else should not remain overnight unburied. Why? Because if they do this, "he is compared to the beasts that perish." Just as animals do not manifest the holy spirit, so too the body without spirit is like an animal. It is forbidden to view a divine form without life,[A] and it is forbidden to disgrace it after death, as we see in Moed Katan in the story of Rabbah bar bar Hana and Rav Hamnuna, who showed honor to each other.

The forces of impurity desire to clothe themselves in a body made in the supernal image. When a person dies an unusual death (God forbid), it causes greater pain to his divine image,[1] especially one who is hanged, for there the forces of impurity gather more than with other deaths. Perhaps because one who is hanging is suspended in air, many evil spirits gather there, which is why the Torah commands, "his body shall not remain all night upon the tree" (Deuteronomy 21:23). Divine curse resides in the place of hanging, where the air becomes corrupted. This is also the reason for distancing oneself from excrement and similar things.

In Zohar (176) it states that it is good to be buried in the ground, even for the wicked.[2] Some place lime in the grave, which is a good custom as it dissolves and washes away the serpent's impurity. See also page 141 regarding Israelites who die in the

[A] Or: "It is forbidden to gaze upon the human form, which reflects the divine image, when it is devoid of life" — This alternative clarifies that the 'divine form' referred to is actually the human body as a reflection of the divine image, which might not be immediately clear in the original translation.

[1] The concept that unusual deaths cause 'pain' to the divine image within a person reflects the kabbalistic understanding that humans are created in God's image in a profound metaphysical sense, not merely symbolically.

[2] This statement reflects the Jewish value of 'kavod ha-met' (honoring the dead), which applies universally regardless of the deceased's moral status. Proper burial is considered a fundamental right for all humans created in the divine image.

[i] This references Deuteronomy 21:23, which states that a hanged man is 'a curse of God.' The author explains this as indicating that the space around a suspended body becomes spiritually corrupted, attracting impure forces.

בו עד שיקבר ושם ביאר משכן נפש רוח נשמה אחר הפטירה כל אחד כמדרגתו: [i]

Land versus outside the Land. It states that one who dies outside the Land has the spirit of impurity dwelling in him until he is buried. There it explains the dwelling place of the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah after death, each according to its level.[1] 230R

פרק כ״ח

Chapter 28

סוד צדוק הדין וההבראה בביצים או בעדשים כפי מנהג הקדום אמרו רבנן במס׳ חלה שעסת הכלבים היא מטמאה טומאת אוכלים[ii] וזה להיותם מותר הקדשים העליונים וזהו חלקו מלחם עליון כדי שתתפרנס מן הימין ולא יוסיף הדינין ע״ד לא אוסיף עוד לקלל את האדמה שפי׳ פ׳ בחוקתי לא אתן עוד תוספת לדינים רק כפי מה

The mystery of Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment)[2] and the mourners' meal with eggs or lentils according to ancient custom: Our Rabbis taught in Tractate Challah that the dough prepared for dogs imparts food impurity. This is because these items are the remnants of the supernal holy offerings,[3] representing their portion from the heavenly bread, so that they may be sustained from the right side (Chesed/kindness) without increasing judgments.[4] This follows the principle: "I will not again curse the ground," which is explained 5R 10R

[1] The text alludes to the kabbalistic teaching that after death, the three components of the soul separate and dwell in different realms: the nefesh (vital soul) remains near the grave, the ruach (spirit) ascends to the lower Garden of Eden, and the neshamah (higher soul) ascends to the upper realms.

[2] This concept refers to the Jewish practice of accepting God's judgment, particularly in times of grief. The Hebrew term 'צידוק הדין' literally means 'justifying the judgment' and refers both to a specific prayer recited at funerals and to the broader spiritual attitude of accepting divine will without question.

[3] The author is establishing a mystical framework where even seemingly mundane items like dough for dogs contain sparks of holiness. This perspective, common in kabbalistic thought, sees all physical reality as containing divine elements that can be elevated through proper intention.

[4] In Kabbalah, the divine attributes are often arranged in a structural diagram called the Tree of Life, with Chesed (loving-kindness) on the right side and Gevurah (judgment/severity) on the left. The author is using this spatial metaphor to explain spiritual dynamics.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel 199b — This Zohar passage explains why the mourning period lasts thirty days, connecting it to the spiritual reality that the soul remains near the body for this period before ascending higher. The author uses this to explain both burial practices and mourning customs. | Cf. Zohar, Vayakhel 211 — The reference to souls being purified in the River of Fire (Nahar Dinur) explains the spiritual processes that occur after death. This creates a parallel between physical purification rituals (tahara) performed on the body and spiritual purification of the soul in higher realms. | Cf. Isaiah 19:25 — The author uses this biblical verse to support his kabbalistic explanation of how Egypt, despite being outside the Holy Land, can still participate in holiness through the process of spiritual 'sweetening' that transforms negative forces into positive ones. | Cf. Psalms 49:13 — This verse is interpreted to provide a biblical basis for the Jewish practice of prompt burial. The author connects this verse to the kabbalistic understanding that delay in burial leaves the body vulnerable to impure spiritual forces. | Cf. Deuteronomy 21:23 — This biblical command about not leaving the body of an executed criminal hanging overnight is interpreted kabbalistically as protecting the divine image in which humans are created from excessive exposure to impure forces that gather around a suspended body. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Kedoshim 83 — This reference to a section of the Zohar develops the theological understanding of the human body's relationship to the earth, which has implications for burial practices and the decomposition process after death.

[ii] The author references a teaching from Tractate Challah regarding dough prepared for dogs being susceptible to food impurity. This somewhat obscure reference sets up his mystical interpretation that connects leftover or secondary items with spiritual significance.

שתוכל לקבל האדמה. וזהו
ויספתי עליכם מכה פי׳ אתן
תוספת מלמעלה לכח הדין
לא חס ושלום שישפע הדין
רק פחות מפגם החוטא וכר״מ
פי׳ כי שבע על חטאתיכם ר״ל
שגם מדה הנקרא שבע גם היא
מתרחקת עבור עונות ישראל על
דלא הקדימת קיסטא לבנאה ואז
נקראת שבע וכשהיא ביחוד עם
בעלה נקראת בת שבע. פוק חזי
בפ׳ בחקתי דף קט״ו ע״א ופי׳
הכפירים שואגים לטרף דהיינו
רמז נזיד עדשים סוד הדין
ולבקש מאל אכלם היינו סוד
לחם. ואמרו בזהר כי תבשיל
שנתן יעקב לאחיו תבר חילא
ותוקפא דדמא סומקא[i] ועל
ההוא תבשילא איזדבן ליה
לעבדא וזבין בכירותיה ליעקב.
מזה נבין כי אכילת האבל הוא
בכוונת לשבר כח הדין המתגבר
עליו. ויין נברא לנחם בו אבלים
שבכח היין המשמח יין המשכר
יגוע ואיו[ii] בסוד ויבא לו ויין
וישת דכל חידו אשתכח ביה וסוד
היין בגבורה ויהיה לבן בשיטה
אל החסד ואדום בשיטה אל
הדין ויקרא טוב כשימזג במים
מצד החסד ששם הטוב. ולכן
הנהגתי בביתי בקדוש והבדלה
ובכל מין ברכה שהיא על היין
ליצוק בתוכו בג׳ פעמים לפחות
ג׳ טיפין מים[iii] וכ״ש ביין הניתן

in Parashat Bechukotai to mean: "I will not add more judgments beyond what the earth can bear."

This is the meaning of "I will add to you a plague"—I will add power from above to the force of judgment, but Heaven forbid that judgment should flow in a measure exceeding the blemish caused by the sinner. In Ra'aya Mehemna, it explains "sevenfold for your sins," meaning that even the attribute called "seven" distances itself because of Israel's sins,[1] for they did not prepare the measure for building, and then it is called "seven," but when it unites with its husband, it is called "Bat-Sheva" (daughter of seven). 15R 20R

Go and see in Parashat Bechukotai, page 115a, where it explains "The young lions roar for prey"—this alludes to the lentil stew, which represents the mystery of judgment, while "seeking their food from God" refers to the mystery of bread. And they said in the Zohar that the dish Jacob gave to his brother broke the strength and power of the red blood,[A] and because of that dish he was sold to him as a servant, and sold his birthright to Jacob. From this we understand that the mourner's meal is intended to break the power of judgment that overwhelms him. 25R 30R 35R

Wine was created to comfort mourners, for through the power of wine that gladdens, the intoxicating wine, he may find relief, in the mystery of "and he brought him wine and he drank," for all joy is found in it. The secret of wine is in Gevurah (strength/judgment), and it becomes white when it inclines toward Chesed (kindness) and red when it inclines toward judgment, and it is called good when mixed with water from the side of Chesed, 40R 45R

[A] Or: "shattered the force and potency of the red blood" — This alternate translation might better convey the forceful nature of the Aramaic terms 'חילא' and 'תוקפא', emphasizing the transformative power attributed to the lentil stew in kabbalistic interpretation.

[1] This refers to the sefirah of Malkhut (Kingdom), which is sometimes called 'seven' because it is the seventh of the lower sefirot. When it is separated from Tiferet (sometimes referred to as its 'husband'), it represents a state of cosmic disharmony caused by human sin.

[i] The text cites the Zohar's mystical interpretation of Jacob's lentil stew as having power to 'break the strength and power of the red blood,' referring to Esau's nature. The Aramaic phrase 'תבר חילא ותוקפא דדמא סומקא' emphasizes the potency attributed to this food in kabbalistic thought.

[ii] The text presents a distinctive view that wine was specifically created to comfort mourners, attributing a divine purpose to wine in the context of mourning rituals. This reflects the Jewish approach of finding spiritual meaning in seemingly mundane aspects of ritual practice.

[iii] The author shares his personal ritual practice of adding three drops of water to wine three times during blessings. This reveals that the text combines traditional mystical teachings with the author's own innovations and customs.

לאבל שצריך מזיגה כי נברא יין
לנחם אבלים ובמזיגה יקרא יין
טוב. וכוונו שלא יזכה לטעם
הבינה הנקרא עה״ב ויין המשומר
50 אף אם יכנס בג״ע בשכר שאר
מצותיו ויש יין המשומר בענביו
ששת ימי בראשית שהם שש
ספירות הבנין ובשהגיע שם ולא
עבר דרך דין הגבורה אז נקרא
55 יין משומר ויפה מעצמו וזהו רמז
תרומה טמאה הנשרפת וקרבנות
טמאים ושעירים הנשרפים ונזיד
עדשים הוא מותר הקדרה שכבר
אכלו הקדושים יצחק וכחות
60 הקדושה שהיו נהנים מהלולא
דצדיק. הגם שלמטה מצד גוף
יצחק היה יום אבל כי הצדיק
אבד לדורו אבד. ואחר אכילת
הקדושים באכלו של אברהם
65 אבינו נתן מותר הקדרה למאן
דבעי ליה והם אוכלים דרך
הלעטה על דרך הלעיטהו
לרשע וימות אם רעב שונאך
האכילהו לחם וכו׳ כי גחלים
70 אתה חותה[i] שאין השפע ההוא
ראוי להם רק לבלעם כחיה
שבלעה אדם מזוין וחרב פיפיות
בידו שהורגה בתוך מעיה כמ״ש
הכתוב עת אשר שלט אדם באדם
75 לרע לו דאדם בליעל. ולכן בעי
לתקנא פתוריה בעת אכילתו כמי
שאוכל לפני המלך שמשלחן גבוה
קא זכי ולא אכיל מהפקרא ח״ו.
עיין בר״מ פ׳ פנחס דף רמ״ה.
80 ואחת מכוונות ההבראה לדעתי
מלבד מה שנכתוב לקמן תהיה
להורות כי בחות החסד מזמנים
להשפיע לנשמת הנפטר מלחם
ענג ומיין המשומר ומסתלק
85 מליזון מלאם אנשים שמוצאו מן
הארץ ויש בו סיג כדאמרן לעיל

where goodness resides. Therefore, I established the practice in my home during Kiddush, Havdalah, and every blessing over wine to pour into it at least three drops of water three times, especially for wine given to a mourner, which requires mixing, because 50R
wine was created to comfort mourners, and when mixed it is called good wine.

They intended that one should not merit to taste the Binah (Understanding) called the World to Come and the preserved wine, even if one enters the Garden 55R
of Eden as reward for their other commandments. There is wine preserved in its grapes from the six days of creation, representing the six Sefirot of construction,[1] and when it reaches there without passing through the judgment of Gevurah, it is called 60R
preserved wine, naturally beautiful. This alludes to the impure terumah that is burned, impure sacrifices, and goats that are burned.

The lentil stew represents the remainder of the pot after the holy ones—Isaac and the forces 65R
of holiness—had already eaten and enjoyed the celebration of the righteous. Even though below, from the perspective of Isaac's body, it was a day of mourning, for "the righteous one is lost to his generation." After the holy ones ate during the 70R
mourning of our father Abraham, the remainder of the pot was given to whoever wanted it, and they eat it by gorging, following the principle: "Feed the wicked and let him die; if your enemy is hungry, feed him bread, etc., for you will heap coals of 75R
fire on his head." This divine flow is not fitting for them; it's like a wild animal that swallowed an armed man with a double-edged sword in his hand who kills it from within its innards, as Scripture states: "A time when man rules over man to his 80R
detriment"—referring to a wicked person.

Therefore, one must set his table properly when eating, like one who eats before the King, for he receives from the high table and does not eat from ownerless property, Heaven forbid. See Ra'aya 85R
Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas, page 245. One of the

[1] This refers to the six lower divine attributes (Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netzach, Hod, and Yesod) that are collectively called the 'Sefirot of Construction' because they are understood to be involved in the ongoing construction and maintenance of creation.

[i] This is a reference to Proverbs 25:21-22, which is given a striking interpretation in this context. Rather than emphasizing kindness to enemies, the author interprets it as suggesting that providing certain spiritual foods to the unworthy can be harmful to them, like 'heaping coals of fire on their head.'

ועולה לאכול מלחם השמים
מזיהרא עילאה ולכן אין אוכלים
סעודה ראשונה משל האבל כי
כחות הדין עתה שולטים בביתו
ובכל אשר לו ואנו צריכים
להשפיעו מכחות החסד ואין
מאכלו בריאה לו להיותו עתה
מצד כחות הדין ואותם שהיו
נוהגים להברותו בבשר ויין
מסייע לדעת זה ומקום שנהגו
להברות בבצים או בעדשים
יהיה כפי כוונת אמרם שבשל
יעקב עדשים להברות את האבל
שהיא מגולגלת ואין לה פה[i] הורו
כי סוד זה מלכות הנקראת
גלגל ואין לה פה להשפיע לחוץ
והיינו בסוד אדמימותה שבאשר
היא פועלת דין כתיב אכלה
ומחתה פיה וגו׳ לזה יסתם
פיה ויתוקן הגלגל האדום וזהו
וידום אהרן[ii] והיינו סוד צידוק
הדין להראות תגבורת הקדושה
והחיצונים נבדלים ממקור האדם
וסותמת פיה שלא ינקו ובבוד
אלהים הסתר דבר:[iii]

intentions of the mourners' meal, in my opinion, besides what we will write below, is to indicate that the forces of kindness are ready to bestow upon the soul of the departed from the bread of delight and the preserved wine. The soul rises from being nourished by human food that comes from the earth and contains impurity, as we mentioned above, and ascends to eat from the heavenly bread of supernal radiance.

Therefore, one does not eat the first meal from the mourner's food, because the forces of judgment now rule over his house[1] and all that belongs to him, and we need to bestow upon him from the forces of kindness. His food is not suitable for him now because it comes from the forces of judgment. Those who used to comfort the mourner with meat and wine support this view, and places where they used to comfort with eggs or lentils followed the intention behind the saying that Jacob cooked lentils to comfort the mourner. The lentil is round and has no mouth, indicating that this mystery relates to Malkhut (Kingdom), which is called a wheel and has no mouth to influence outwardly.[A] This relates to the mystery of its redness, for when it exercises judgment, it is written: "She eats and wipes her mouth, etc." Therefore, its mouth is closed, and the red

[A] Or: "they taught that this mystery pertains to Malkhut (Kingdom), which is called a sphere and has no opening through which to channel influence outward" — This alternative more explicitly conveys the kabbalistic concept of Malkhut as a spherical sefirah that, in its state of judgment, cannot properly transmit divine flow to lower realms.

[1] According to kabbalistic thought, when death occurs, forces of judgment temporarily dominate the space and possessions of the mourner. This provides a mystical rationale for the traditional practice where neighbors provide the first meal to mourners rather than having them prepare their own food.

[i] The text references a rabbinic tradition (from Bava Batra 16b) that lentils are traditionally served to mourners because they are round and have no 'mouth' (opening), symbolizing the mourner who is silent like a stone. The author elaborates on this with kabbalistic interpretations.

[ii] This references Leviticus 10:3, where Aaron remained silent after the death of his sons Nadab and Abihu. The text interprets this silence as a form of Tzidduk HaDin (accepting divine judgment), connecting it with the symbolism of the lentil's lack of a 'mouth.'

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Bechukotai — The author uses this Zohar passage to establish a mystical connection between lentils and divine judgment, reinforcing the kabbalistic framework for understanding mourning rituals. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas — This reference establishes that eating should be done with spiritual awareness, as if in the divine presence, which contextualizes the mourner's meal as a ritual with cosmic significance rather than merely a physical comfort. | Cf. Biblical story of Jacob and Esau — The author interprets this biblical narrative through a mystical lens, suggesting that the lentils had power to 'break the strength of the red blood,' metaphorically referring to Esau's nature and the forces of judgment. This establishes a spiritual precedent for the use of lentils in mourning rituals. | Cf. Tractate Challah — This rabbinic teaching is used as a basis for explaining how remnants or leftovers (like the mourning foods) can still contain spiritual power and significance, despite being 'secondary' items.

wheel[A] is rectified.[1] This is the meaning of "Aaron was silent," which is the mystery of Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment)—to demonstrate the triumph of holiness while the external forces are separated from the human source, and it closes its mouth so they cannot draw sustenance. And "the glory of God is to conceal a matter."

פרק כ״ט

בענין סדר צדוק הדין, יראה לי הפעוט הכותב כי תקנו לנו להצדיק דין שמים בו עשרים פעמים כנגד השני דמעות שהם מדה״ד הקשה ומדה״ד הרפה הכלולים כל אחת מי׳ גבורות האחת המלכות ער״ש ורע״ש בדיניה המיוחדת עם הוד דוה והיא פועלת הדין בתחתונים. השנית היא גבורה שממנה מקור הרוגז ח״ו. והיא פחם לגחלים ועצים לאש וכשאדם בולם עצמו כמי שאין לו פה גורם שהחצון ג״כ אין לו פה לינק מתגבורת הדין. ואהרן שהיה איש החסד הוא בראש כל הדוממים קבל שכר כי אם ח״ו היה פוצה פיו היה משפיע לגבורות השפעת החסד. וממנו ילמוד אפי׳ בר נש זעיר כי ודאי יקבל שכר על שתיקותו וכ״ש בשמברך על הרעה מעין הטובה בלב טוב ושמח ביסורין לתקון שכינה ודאי בזה המקדש העליון מתטהר

Chapter 29

Regarding the order of Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment), it appears to me, the humble writer, that they established for us to justify divine judgment twenty times, corresponding to the two tears that represent harsh judgment and mild judgment,[A] each containing ten powers of strength. The first is Malkhut with its aspects of "ER"SH" and "RE"SH" in its unique judgments together with the suffering Hod, and it enacts judgment in the lower worlds. The second is Gevurah, which is the source of wrath, God forbid. It is like coal for embers and wood for fire, and when a person restrains himself as if he has no mouth,[B] he causes the external forces also to have no mouth with which to draw sustenance from the intensification of judgment.

Aaron, who was a man of kindness, is foremost among all the silent ones and received reward, because if, God forbid, he had opened his mouth, he would have channeled the flow of kindness to the powers of severity. From him even an insignificant person should learn that he will certainly receive reward for his silence, and all the more so when he blesses for the bad as he does for the good, with a good heart, rejoicing in suffering for the sake of rec-

[A] Or: "the red sphere" — While 'wheel' is a literal translation of 'גלגל', in this kabbalistic context it might refer to the spherical nature of divine emanations, particularly Malkhut in its aspect of judgment, and 'sphere' might better convey this cosmic imagery.

[A] Or: "twenty times, corresponding to the two tears which are the attribute of harsh judgment and the attribute of lenient judgment" — This translation more directly conveys the kabbalistic terminology, where מדה״ד is an abbreviation for מידת הדין (middat ha-din), literally 'the attribute of judgment.' The concepts of harsh and lenient judgment are fundamental categories in Kabbalah, and the direct reference to them as attributes rather than simply 'representing' them might be more precise.

[B] Or: "restrains himself as one who is speechless" — The metaphor of being 'speechless' might better capture the concept of complete restraint in Jewish ethical literature, where silence in the face of suffering is considered a virtue. This translation maintains the meaning while using an idiom that might be more natural in English.

[1] This is a reference to Malkhut (the divine attribute of Kingdom) when it is in a state of judgment, symbolized by the color red. The author suggests that the mourning rituals involving round foods like lentils help 'rectify' or restore balance to this spiritual attribute.

ע״י הדין המושפע למטה והוא עושה עצמו מזבח כפרה לתקון שמים כדאמרו בתקונים שכאשר קבל עליו אדם הראשון הדין מיד נתקן הפגם. וכן בקבלת האדם כל גזרת הדין ובפרט קרובי המת מתקנים הפגם שנפגם למעלה וזהו ואתה צדיק על כל הבא עלינו כל איזה צורך שיצטרך לתקון גבוה על כל הבא עלינו כי אמת עשית ותקנת ואין דבר רע יורד מלמעלה ואנחנו הרשענו כי נדבקנו בחצונים. וזהו הצור תמים פעלו כי כל דרכיו לתקון מדת המשפט. וכן על זה הדרך בכל הצדקת דין שמים הנזכר בסדר צדוק הדין ויוכל המשכיל לכוין כפי הבחינות וכפי ענין המתראה בפ׳ או בסדר שאומר ויכוין בזה להמתיק דין הקדוש ולהבליעו במקורו כי שם יתבסם ויתמתק ולסכור פה דוברי עתק בשתיקתו. ובמה שכתבנו יוכל המשכיל להוסיף חכמה ודעת בהבנת כל בבא מסדר צדוק הדין ע״פ סדר מתוק עשרים גבורות הנזכר. ואין להאריך במקום שאמרו לקצר. אח״כ מזרזין לאדם בו שיפשפש במעשיו כי עתיד לעמוד בדין ומזכירים דם עבדיו השפוך בשנת תתנ״ו וקל״ו כי אין לך ביסום הדין גדול מזה. ואח״כ מבקשים על הנפטר רחמים בארבע מדרגות אבי״ע אבות עולם ירמוז באצילות שנשמת האבות הם מרכבה לרוכב בשמי שמי קדם מלאכי שלום יהיו בבריאה מקום השרפים. גבעות עולם יהיו ביצירה מקום החיות. שומרי גנזי גן עדן בעשיה ששם ג״ע תחתון והאופנים ומלת זאת

tifying the Divine Presence. Surely through this, the supernal sanctuary is purified through the judgment channeled below, and he makes himself an altar of atonement for heavenly rectification. As they said in the Tikkunim, when Adam accepted the judgment upon himself, the spiritual damage was immediately repaired. Similarly, when a person accepts all divine decrees, especially the relatives of the deceased, they repair the damage that occurred above. This is the meaning of "You are righteous concerning all that comes upon us"—whatever is needed for supernal rectification that comes upon us—"for You have acted truthfully and we have acted wickedly" because we attached ourselves to the external forces. This is why "The Rock, His work is perfect," because all His ways are for rectifying the attribute of justice.

This pattern applies to all justifications of divine judgment mentioned in the Tzidduk HaDin order, and the insightful person can direct his intention according to the aspects and according to the matter that appears in the passage or order he recites. He should intend through this to sweeten the holy judgment and absorb it into its source, for there it becomes fragrant and sweetened, and to shut the mouth of those who speak arrogantly through his silence. With what we have written, the insightful person can add wisdom and knowledge in understanding each section of the Tzidduk HaDin order according to the sweet arrangement of the twenty powers mentioned. One should not elaborate where they said to be brief.

Afterward, we encourage the person to examine his deeds, for he will stand in judgment in the future, and we mention the blood of His servants spilled in the years 4856 (1096) and 4936 (1176), for there is no greater sweetening of judgment than this. Then we request mercy for the departed through the four levels of ABYA (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah): "Fathers of the World" alludes to Atzilut, where the souls of the Patriarchs are a chariot for the One who rides in the highest heavens;[A] "Angels of Peace" are in Beriah, the place of the Seraphim; "Hills of

[A] Or: "the four worlds ABYA (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah): "Patriarchs of the Universe" alludes to the world of Atzilut, where the souls of the Patriarchs serve as a divine chariot for the Rider of the ancient highest heavens" — This alternate translation more explicitly identifies ABYA as 'the four worlds' and translates אבות עולם as 'Patriarchs of the Universe,' which might be more precise in this mystical context. It also clarifies the metaphor of the divine chariot (merkavah) which is a central concept in Jewish mysticism.

שהיא השכינה כדכתיב בזאת יבא אהרן בזכות הנפטר ובסוד הרחמים ומתוקן בחות דין אלו
70 היא תקבל נשמתו בחיקה ותאמר לו שלום בואו. ואחר צדוק הדין אומרים הקדיש שסגולתו בכל מקום לתברא מנעולין דפרזלא בתחלת ענין ובסוף
75 ענין לפתוח השמים והשערים ולשמור התפלה או הקריאה וכל שאר העניינים מן המקטרגים ומתנכרים בו ואין להם כח לקנתר ולקטרג ועדיף כח קדיש
80 זה שנרמז בו הטל היורד מא״א להוסיף חיות ושפע רב לכל הספירות ולשובני עפר בלי מספר וצמיחת האור אל הישועה מיסוד עליון ונביעת המקור
85 העליון לתקון משיחנו. וכבר נודע כי סגולת הקדיש לבטל אשו של גיהנם ולהכניע בחות הזרים. והבן בכח הקדיש מוציא אביו מיד החצונים ומכניסו לגן
90 עדן. ובעי למימר ליה בלישנא דסטרא אחרא. ולאתבא בחילא תקיף אמן בגין דאיתבר חיליה דסטרא אחרא ויסתלק יקרא דקב״ה על כולא ואדכר לבנוי
95 ואדכר לשמיה כדאיתא בזהר פ׳ תרומה והוא סוד הקדושה למטה בת״ת ומלכות הממשיכים שפע החכמה מלמעלה עליהם ות״ת הוא קדיש ומלכות היא
100 קדושה וחכמה הוא קדוש המעלה ת״ת ומלכות לחכמה ששם דו פרצופין כנודע. ובכל קדיש מצנן גיהנם שעתא ופלגא. הנה כי בהמתקת בחות הגבורה.
105 ובדמימת האבל והצדקת דין והמנחמים יבוסם הדין ויתוקן הכל בחסד אל. וקדיש זה הוא דבריו של מת שהם מתפללים עליהם ואין צריך להרחיק ארבע
110 אמות:[i]

the World" are in Yetzirah, the place of the Chayot (living angels); "Guardians of the treasures of the Garden of Eden" are in Asiyah, where the lower Garden of Eden and the Ophanim (angelic wheels) 70R
are found. And the word "Zot" (this), which represents the Shekhinah, as it is written "With this (zot) shall Aaron enter," by the merit of the departed and through the mystery of compassion and the sweetened forces of judgment—she will receive his soul in 75R
her bosom and say to him, "Enter in peace."

After Tzidduk HaDin, we recite the Kaddish, whose special power in every place is to break iron locks, at the beginning and end of a matter, to open the heavens and gates, and to protect the prayer or 80R
reading and all other matters from accusers. They are unable to challenge and accuse when confronted with it. The power of this Kaddish is superior because it alludes to the dew that descends from Arich Anpin to add vitality and abundant flow to 85R
all the Sefirot and to the countless dwellers in dust, and the sprouting of light toward salvation from the supernal foundation, and the flowing of the supernal source for the rectification of our Messiah.

It is already known that the special quality of the 90R
Kaddish is to nullify the fire of Gehenna and subdue the foreign powers. And the son, through the power of Kaddish, brings his father out from the grasp of the external forces and brings him into the Garden of Eden. One must recite it in the language of the Other 95R
Side and respond with forceful "Amen" because this breaks the power of the Other Side, elevates the glory of the Holy One, blessed be He, over everything, and invokes remembrance for His children and His name, as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah. 100R
This is the mystery of holiness below in Tiferet and Malkhut, which draw down the flow of wisdom from above upon them. Tiferet is "Kaddish" and Malkhut is "Kedushah," and Chokhmah is "Kadosh" which elevates Tiferet and Malkhut to Chokhmah, where 105R
there are two visages, as is known. With every Kaddish, Gehenna is cooled for an hour and a half.

Thus, through the sweetening of the powers of Gevurah, the mourner's silence, the justification of judgment, and the comforters, the judgment is sweet- 110R

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The author uses this reference to establish the kabbalistic authority for the practice of reciting Kaddish for the dead, particularly explaining how it works on a cosmic level to break 'iron locks' and elevate the soul through various spiritual realms. | Cf. Tikkunim (Tikkunei Zohar) — This reference establishes a theological foundation for the practice

ened and everything is rectified through God's kindness. This Kaddish represents the words of the deceased, as they pray for them, and it is not necessary to distance oneself four cubits.

פרק ל׳

Chapter 30

בימי חכמי המשנה והגמרא בחזרתם מבית הקברות היו עושים שבעה מעמדות ושבעה מושבות ומברכין ברכת רחבה
5 הכתובה בס׳ הכלבו[i] וזה כדי לעורר עליו ברכה מרחובות הנהר לכבות אש דין הקודח. וכדאמרי׳ במס׳ ברכות ובבא בתרא פ׳ ו׳ אמרי׳ כי הז׳
10 מעמדות היו נגד ז׳ הבלים שבס׳ קהלת[ii] ובכל ישיבה ועמידה

In the days of the Sages of the Mishnah and Talmud, upon returning from the cemetery, they would perform seven stations and seven sittings,[1] and recite the "Blessing of Expansiveness" recorded in the book Kolbo. This was done to arouse blessing for 5R
the deceased from "the expanses of the river" to extinguish the burning fire of judgment.[2] As stated in Tractate Berakhot and Bava Batra chapter 6, these seven stations corresponded to the seven "breaths" mentioned in the Book of Ecclesiastes.[A] At each 10R
sitting and standing, representing the mystery

[A] Or: "the seven "vanities" mentioned in the Book of Ecclesiastes" — The Hebrew word 'havalim' (הבלים) in Ecclesiastes is traditionally translated as 'vanities' in English biblical translations, though in kabbalistic contexts it refers to divine 'breaths' or emanations. Either translation would be appropriate depending on whether to emphasize the biblical or mystical context.

[1] These 'stations' and 'sittings' were ritual pauses and moments of reflection performed by mourners and funeral attendees when returning from burial. The exact form of these practices has been lost, but they involved stopping at designated points and reciting prayers or reflections.

[2] The metaphor of 'extinguishing fire' reflects the kabbalistic understanding that death invokes divine judgment, which manifests as spiritual 'fire.' The ritual stations were believed to mitigate this judgment through the counteracting power of divine mercy.

of Tzidduk HaDin (justification of divine judgment), connecting the contemporary ritual to a primordial pattern established by Adam himself. It suggests that accepting divine judgment with equanimity has cosmic significance in repairing spiritual damage. | Cf. Jewish martyrdom during the Crusades — By invoking these historical tragedies, the author suggests that remembering collective Jewish suffering and martyrdom serves as a powerful means of 'sweetening judgment' in kabbalistic terms. The memory of those who died al kiddush Hashem (sanctifying God's name) is presented as having ongoing spiritual efficacy in tempering divine severity. | Cf. Biblical verse "You are righteous concerning all that comes upon us" — This biblical reference provides textual authority for the practice of Tzidduk HaDin, showing that acceptance of divine judgment even in difficult circumstances has roots in the biblical tradition of acknowledging God's justice while recognizing human failings. | Cf. The Rock, His work is perfect — This reference from the Song of Moses affirms God's perfect justice, reinforcing the theological premise that divine judgment, even when appearing harsh, always serves a rectifying purpose in the cosmic order. | Cf. With this (zot) shall Aaron enter — This biblical reference is reinterpreted through a kabbalistic lens, where 'zot' (this) becomes a symbol of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). The author uses this connection to explain how the Divine Presence receives the soul of the departed after the Tzidduk HaDin ritual is completed.

[i] This refers to a special blessing found in Sefer Kolbo, a medieval compendium of Jewish law and custom. The 'Blessing of Expansiveness' was recited specifically after returning from a cemetery.

[ii] The Book of Ecclesiastes contains seven instances of the word 'hevel' (vanity/breath), which in kabbalistic interpretation represent divine emanations that sustain creation. The seven stations performed after burial ritually correspond to these cosmic forces.

לסוד אור ישר וחוזר[i] היו
מעוררים כלליות מדות החסד
שבכל ספירה וספירה ממטה
למעלה עד מדת חסד אל למען
יקדמו פנים המאירים לארץ
ולדרים ולכן אין עושים דברים
אלו בפחות מי׳ דשכינה קדמא
ואתיא. וכתוב בירושלמי
דכלאים כי עשו לר׳ י״ח
מושבות[ii] או שהספידוהו בי״ח
בתי כנסיות וכתב בעל עין
יעקב שזה עשו לרמוז שהוא
ח״י. ואגרא דהספדא דלויי
פי׳ רש״י להרים קול ואולי זה
יהיה בהצדקת דין שמים וסודו
בנזכר לעיל מלבד שגם בהזכרת
שבחי המת האמתיים מעוררים
המדות עליונות המאירים מהם
והשמעת הקול יהיה על דרך
שנא׳ בב״ג ונשמע קולו בבואו
אל הקדש[iii] ואמרו בגין דיצטריך
קלא דישתמע וברכאן ישרון על
עלמא בגיניה כמו שהוא היה
שלם בחשן ואפוד זה פנים וזה
אחור והיה רומז יחוד אופנים

of direct and reflected light, they would awaken the collective attributes of lovingkindness within each sefirah, ascending from below upward[1] until reaching the attribute of God's lovingkindness, so that illuminated countenances would precede the earth and its inhabitants.[A] Therefore, these practices are not performed with fewer than ten men, for "the Divine Presence precedes and arrives."[2] 15R

It is written in the Jerusalem Talmud of Kilayim that they arranged eighteen sittings for Rabbi [Judah the Prince], or that they eulogized him in eighteen synagogues. The author of Ein Yaakov wrote that they did this to symbolize that he was "chai" (alive, with numerical value 18). Regarding the reward for a eulogy, Rashi explained that it refers to raising one's voice. Perhaps this relates to the justification of divine judgment[3] and its secret as mentioned above. Additionally, when mentioning the true praises of the deceased, one awakens the supernal attributes that illuminate from them. The raising of the voice follows the principle stated about the High Priest: "And his voice shall be heard when he enters the holy place," and they said that this is necessary so that the voice is heard and blessings rest upon the world through him.[B] 20R 25R 30R 35R

[A] Or: "so that radiant faces might greet the earth and those who dwell upon it" — This alternate translation provides a more poetic rendering that captures the metaphorical nature of divine light spreading to the world and its inhabitants.

[B] Or: "and blessings shall flow upon the world because of him" — The Aramaic term 'yishrun' has a sense of flowing or settling, and this alternate translation captures the dynamic nature of blessings descending to the world.

[1] The text describes a spiritual process where ritual actions in the physical world affect the metaphysical structure of the ten sefirot (divine emanations). The seven stations create an upward flow of energy through these emanations, reaching ultimately to divine mercy.

[2] This Aramaic phrase 'shekhina kadma ve-atya' is a rabbinic expression indicating that when ten men gather, the Divine Presence is already there among them, making their prayers and rituals particularly effective.

[3] This refers to the ritual known as 'tzidduk ha-din,' where mourners formally accept God's judgment despite their grief. The raised voice during this recitation is understood to have cosmic significance in the heavenly realms.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'or yashar' (direct light) and 'or chozer' (reflected light), describing how divine emanation descends from God to creation and then ascends back, a fundamental principle in Jewish mysticism that is applied here to funeral rituals.

[ii] The number eighteen (י״ח) is significant because it corresponds to the numerical value of the Hebrew word 'chai' (חי), meaning 'alive.' The eighteen sittings for Rabbi Judah the Prince symbolically affirmed his continued spiritual life despite physical death.

[iii] This is a reference to Exodus 28:35, which describes the High Priest's garments, specifically the bells attached to his robe that would sound as he entered the Holy Place. The text draws a parallel between this Temple service and the raised voice of eulogy.

בחיות[i] וזהו סוד תפלין וקשר
תפלין פנים ואחור אספקלריא
המאירה ושאינה מאירה והסוד
קול ודבור שאינם מתפרשים
לעולם ועוד רמזו בקול ודבור
והבל אור ישר ואור חוזר זה
עולה וזה יורד וצריך להרים
קול דאשתמע לקלא עילאה דלא
אשתמע בסוד הזעקה שאמרנו
למעלה והמת הגורם זה יתברך
מאלהי אמן. והמספיד נענש
אם אינו משבחו כפי מעלתו
כמו שאירע לבר אבון ולבר
קפוק במ״ק ומההוא טייעא
דנתור ככיה ושיניה.[ii] ודרכי
ההספד הראוים לגדולים למדו
אותם רבותינו בספור הדברים
שהיו אומרים הספדנים על
פטירת רבותינו הקדושים
בבבלי ובירושלמי ואמרו בשבת
מהספדו של אדם ניכר אם הוא
בן העולם הבא[iii] ולכבודם היו
מניחים ס״ת קרוב למטתם וגם
לרבות ההספד והבכי והיה
מהם מי שלא היו רוצים שיניחו
ס״ת על מטתו כדאיתא במ״ק.
וההספד הוא במקום רבים
לחכמי׳ כדאמרינן במגילה פ׳
בני העיר ר״ל דספדיה להההוא
דתאני הלכתא בכ״ד שורתא
והיו מושיבין ישיבה על קברם
כדאמרינן בקמא פרק א׳ ומ״ק

Just as the High Priest was complete with the breastplate and ephod—one in front and one behind—which symbolized the unification of the Ophanim with the Chayot, this is the secret of tefillin and the tefillin knot, front and back, the illuminating lens and the non-illuminating lens.[A] The secret is voice and speech which are never separated.[1] They further alluded in voice, speech, and breath to direct light and reflected light—one ascending and one descending. One must raise a voice that is heard to awaken the supernal voice that is not heard, in the mystery of the cry that we mentioned above. The deceased who causes this will be blessed by the God of truth.

A eulogizer is punished if he does not praise the deceased according to his proper stature, as happened to Bar Avun and Bar Kapok in Moed Katan, and to that Arab merchant whose eye and teeth fell out. Our Rabbis taught the proper ways of eulogy fitting for great individuals through the accounts of what eulogizers would say at the passing of our holy Rabbis in the Babylonian and Jerusalem Talmuds. They stated in Shabbat that from a person's eulogy it becomes evident whether he is destined for the World to Come. To honor them, they would place a Torah scroll near their beds to increase lamentation and weeping, though some did not want a Torah scroll placed on their bed, as mentioned in Moed Katan.

The eulogy is delivered in a public place for scholars, as stated in Megillah, chapter "The People of the City," where Resh Lakish eulogized one who taught halakhot in twenty-four rows.[2] They would estab-

[A] Or: "the clear speculum and the unclear speculum" — In Jewish mystical terminology, 'aspaklaria ha-me'irah' and its counterpart are often rendered as 'clear speculum' and 'unclear speculum' in English translations of kabbalistic texts, referring to different qualities of prophetic vision.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that in the divine realm, thought, speech, and action are unified rather than separate as they are in the human realm. The eulogy temporarily achieves a similar unification through the proper raising of the voice.

[2] This refers to a scholar whose students were so numerous that they filled twenty-four rows in the study hall, indicating his exceptional status as a teacher of Torah.

[i] This refers to the unification of different categories of angels (Ophanim/Wheels and Chayot/Holy Beasts) described in Ezekiel's vision. The text connects this celestial unification to the ephod and breastplate worn by the High Priest, which had front and back aspects, and further to the tefillin worn in prayer.

[ii] This refers to a Talmudic account where an inadequate eulogizer suffered the supernatural punishment of losing his eye and teeth, emphasizing the spiritual gravity of properly honoring the deceased.

[iii] The Talmudic teaching that one's eulogy reveals whether they are 'destined for the World to Come' suggests that how one is remembered after death provides insight into their true spiritual status.

ובכתובות ועיין שם במעשה
בפטירת רבינו הקדוש ואמרנו
כי מהספדו של אדם ניכר מי הוא
וכו׳ ראיה זה מאבנר [i]

lish a study session at their graves, as stated in Bava Kamma chapter 1, Moed Katan, and Ketubot. See there the account of the passing of our holy Rabbi [Judah the Prince]. And we have said that from a person's eulogy it becomes evident who he is, etc. The proof for this comes from [the case of] Abner.

דבחמים דוד עליו בכו כל
העם עמו כמה דאמרו בשבת
הא דמחממי ליה ואחים ומשם
נראה כי הבכי והקינה הוא על
הקבר וראשונה להם ההספד
שכן כתיב חגרו שקים לפני אבנר
ובעת הקבורה שהוא התעוררו׳
הרחמים עליו כאשר יבא אז
התחיל לבכות על קברו וכל
ישראל גומלי חסדים אחריו.
ואח״כ קונן עליו כמו שנאמר
ויקונן המלך על אבנר ואז
ויוסיפו כל העם לבכות עליו.
בבכי ראשון עוררו רחמי זעיר.
ובשני רחמים גדולים מאריך. גם
משם ראיתי כי ראוי להתענות
ביום קבורת הצדיקים שכן
דוד לא אבה לטעום לחם או
כל מאומה וייטב בעיני כל

When David warmed himself over Abner,[A] all the people wept with him, as they said in [Tractate] Shabbat: "This was when they warmed him and comforted him." From this it appears that weeping and lamentation occur at the grave, and the eulogy comes first, as it is written, "Gird yourselves with sackcloth before Abner." At the time of burial, which is when compassion for him is aroused[B] as will be explained, David began to weep at his grave, and all Israel, performers of acts of kindness, followed him. Afterward, he lamented over him, as it is said, "And the king lamented over Abner," and then "all the people continued to weep over him."[C] In the first weeping, they aroused the compassion of Zeir [Anpin, the Lesser Countenance]. And in the second, [they aroused] greater compassion from Arich [Anpin, the Long-Faced One]. Also from there I saw that it is proper to fast on the day of burial of the righteous, for David refused to taste bread or anything

[A] Or: "When David mourned over him" — The word 'דבחמים' could be interpreted as 'when he mourned' rather than literally 'warmed himself,' as it's describing David's mourning for Abner. The Hebrew phrase might be referencing the emotional warmth of mourning rather than physical warming.

[B] Or: "the awakening of mercy upon him" — This more literal translation of 'התעוררו הרחמים׳' as 'the awakening of mercy' better preserves the kabbalistic connotation of 'awakening' or 'arousing' spiritual forces.

[C] Or: "all the people increased their weeping over him" — The Hebrew verb 'ויוסיפו' can be translated as either 'continued' or 'increased/added to,' with the latter emphasizing the intensification of the weeping rather than just its continuation.

[i] Cf. Sefer Kolbo — The text references the Sefer Kolbo (Book of Everything), a 14th-century compilation of Jewish law and custom, as the source for the 'Blessing of Expansiveness' recited after returning from a cemetery. This demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok draws on medieval legal sources to establish its ritual frameworks. | Cf. Ecclesiastes — The reference to the 'seven havalim (breaths/vanities)' in Ecclesiastes connects funeral practices to King Solomon's meditation on mortality. In kabbalistic interpretation, these 'breaths' became understood as divine emanations sustaining the world, giving metaphysical significance to the seven stations established after burial. | Cf. Zohar — The passage's discussion of 'direct light' (or ישר) and 'reflected light' (or חוזר) draws directly from Zoharic and Lurianic kabbalistic concepts about how divine emanation descends and returns. The text applies this cosmological framework to explain how ritual actions at funerals affect the soul's journey. | Cf. Exodus 28:35 — The text draws a parallel between the High Priest's service (where his bells must be heard when entering the sanctuary) and the eulogizer who must raise his voice. Both serve as mediators between worlds, with sound functioning as a vehicle for spiritual influence. | Cf. Moed Katan — The text cites cases from this tractate about eulogizers being punished for inadequate eulogies, establishing that proper honor for the dead is not merely social etiquette but a spiritual obligation with consequences.

העם ואנשי יבש גלעד התענו
שבעה ימים על קבורת עצמות
שאול ובניו. ומשבעה מעמדות
הנז׳ נתפשט אצלינו המנהג
לישב ז׳ פעמים ביציאה מבית
הקברות וממה שהעלינו למעלה
בששה מדרגות הטומאה והטהרה
שביעית וגוברת עליהן יהיה
טעם למה יושבין ז׳ פעמים ששה
להבריח הרוחות וא׳ להכין
עצמו לקבלת הטהרה על דרך
וישב העם בקד״ש. ובין קד״ש
ובין בר״ד הם שבעה ואפילו
היכל השביעי מהיכלי התמורות
יש כחות הפורחים באויר [i]

else, "and it pleased all the people." And the men of Jabesh-Gilead fasted for seven days over the burial of the bones of Saul and his sons. From the seven stations mentioned above, our custom has spread to sit seven times when leaving the cemetery. And from what we established above concerning the six levels of impurity[1] with the seventh prevailing over them, this would be the reason why we sit seven times: six to drive away the spirits,[2] and one to prepare oneself to receive purity, following the pattern of "and the people settled in Kadesh."[3] Between "Kadesh" and "Bered" there are seven.[4] Even in the seventh palace of the Palaces of Exchange, there are forces that fly through the air[5]

ומזיקים לצד טומאתן לעשות
נסים בעולם לעומדים בצד
הקדושה ויש לו פתחים מכוונים
נגד הקדושה ומאירה באפילה
ההיא ושם יש מקום לחסידי

They cause harm through their impurity[6] by performing miracles in the world for those who stand on the side of holiness. This [seventh palace] has entrances aligned directly opposite holiness, and it shines in that darkness. There is a place there for

[1]This indicates that the present text is part of a larger work where the author previously explained a system of six levels of impurity with a seventh level that overcomes them. This structural pattern is now being applied to explain the ritual of seven sittings when leaving a cemetery.

[2]The text reveals a protective function of the seven sittings ritual—six of the sittings are understood to provide protection against harmful spiritual entities that might attach to mourners leaving a cemetery, while the seventh sitting prepares one to receive purity again.

[3]This appears to be a reference to Numbers 20:1, where the Israelites settled in Kadesh. The author is using this biblical reference to create a connection between the ritual of sitting seven times and a biblical precedent.

[4]This is likely referring to a mystical interpretation of Genesis 16:14, which mentions Kadesh and Bered in relation to the well where Hagar encountered an angel. The author is suggesting there are seven spiritual stations or levels between these two biblical locations, creating a parallel to the seven sittings in the mourning ritual.

[5]In kabbalistic literature, particularly in discussions of the 'Sitra Achra' (Other Side), there are descriptions of negative spiritual forces that inhabit different domains, including the air. These are understood to be particularly dangerous to humans in spiritually vulnerable states, such as after visiting a cemetery.

[6]The original is somewhat ambiguous about who is causing harm. I've interpreted it as referring to the forces in the seventh palace of exchange mentioned in the previous context.

[i]Cf. Talmud Shabbat — The reference to Tractate Shabbat provides rabbinic authority for the mourning customs described in the text, particularly the sequence of eulogy, weeping, and lamentation. | Cf. 2 Samuel 3:31-39 — The author uses this biblical narrative to derive kabbalistic interpretations about the spiritual effects of different stages of mourning, connecting physical mourning rituals to their impact on divine attributes (Zeir Anpin and Arich Anpin). | Cf. 1 Samuel 31:13 — This reference establishes biblical authority for the practice of fasting on the day of burial of the righteous, using the example of Saul to complement the earlier example of David's fasting after Abner's burial. | Cf. Zohar — The reference to these kabbalistic concepts suggests that the author is interpreting mourning practices within the framework of Lurianic Kabbalah, where different mourning behaviors affect different aspects of the divine configuration. | Cf. Genesis 16:14 — This biblical reference to locations between which there are 'seven' is used as a textual basis for the practice of sitting seven times when leaving a cemetery, connecting physical ritual to biblical precedent.

א״ה הנק׳ כבוד.[i] הנה כי בז׳ ישיבות ובפרט בכח שיר של פגעים[ii] נעלה ונראה אל הר הקדושה. וקודם זה עושים רמז לתחיה כי אז רוח הטומאה יעבור מן הארץ. וזה עם תלישת העשבים מהבית חיים ואומרים ויציצו מעיר כעשב הארץ. ועוד אמרו שהוא להפריש בינם ובין המות ירצו בחות המטמאות הגוף המזדמנות בעת המיתה. ובהשלכתן לאחוריהם רמז כי נשכחתי כמת מלב דכיון דלא איכפת להו למיתי יותר מהאי עלמא כדאמר שמואל לרב יהודה חק בשאול מי יודה לך לכן גם החי שוכח אותו כי גזרה היא על המת שישתכח[iii] להיותו נגזר מחיי עולם הזה ועושה דרור בעולם שכלו ארוך. אך על החי שסבור שהוא מת אינו שוכח אותו כי כמים הפנים לפנים כן לב האדם לאדם. עוד סוד העשב הוא כי יש שדה במדור הראשון שהוא מקום כניסת ההיכלות בכל לילה. ובאותו שדה גדול יש סוד המלאכים שהם מאכל למלכות שמצד חיות הקדש הנקראת בבחינת

the pious among the nations of the world, which is called "Honor."[A] Thus, through the seven stations, and particularly through the power of the "Song of Afflictions" [Psalm 91],[1] we ascend and appear at the mountain of holiness. 115R

Before this, we perform a symbolic gesture pointing to resurrection, for at that time "the spirit of impurity will pass from the earth." This is done by plucking grass from the cemetery while saying, "They will flourish from the city like the grass of the earth" [Psalm 72:16]. It is also said that this separates them [the living] from death,[B] meaning from the forces that defile the body which are present at the time of death. And by throwing the grass behind them, it symbolizes "I am forgotten, like a dead person, from the heart" [Psalm 31:13], since the dead no longer care about this world, as Samuel said to Rav Yehudah, "The decree in Sheol—who will acknowledge You?" [Psalm 6:6]. Therefore, even the living forget the dead, for it is decreed that the dead should be forgotten, as they are cut off from the life of this world and find freedom in the eternal world. However, regarding a living person who is thought to be dead, one does not forget him, for "as water reflects face to face, so the heart of a person to a person" [Proverbs 27:19]. 120R 125R 130R 135R

Another secret of the grass[2] is that there is a field in the first chamber,[C] which is the place where the [heavenly] palaces enter each night. In that great 140R

[A] Or: "known as 'Glory.'" — The Hebrew word 'kavod' can be translated as either 'honor' or 'glory,' with the latter perhaps better conveying the celestial radiance implied in this mystical context.

[B] Or: "to make a distinction between them and death" — This alternative is more literal but might better capture the ritual intention of creating a conceptual separation between the living and death.

[C] Or: "a field in the first celestial dwelling place" — The term 'mador' specifically refers to celestial dwelling places in kabbalistic literature, which might be clearer with this more specific translation.

[1] Shir Shel Pegaim (Song of Afflictions) is the traditional rabbinic designation for Psalm 91, particularly in the Talmud (Shevuot 15b). It was believed to have special protective powers against harmful spiritual forces.

[2] The author employs multiple layers of kabbalistic interpretation for the ritual of plucking grass at cemeteries, moving from simple symbolism to increasingly complex mystical meanings.

[i] This refers to the concept of the 'righteous among the nations' having a place in the World to Come, specifically in an area called 'Honor' within the seventh palace of the celestial realm.

[ii] Shir Shel Pegaim (Song of Afflictions) is the traditional rabbinic name for Psalm 91, believed to have protective powers against harmful spiritual forces and demons. It was customarily recited at funerals and in times of danger.

[iii] This reflects the Talmudic teaching that the dead are eventually forgotten, which is viewed here not as a tragedy but as a divine decree allowing the deceased to fully transition to the next world.

בהמה ועשב זה הוא מזון ושפע
התחתונים. ולהיות כי הנפטר
נסתלק ממזון תחתון הנרמז
בעשב מן הארץ שהוא מאכל
145 לנפשו הבהמית על כן תולשין
העשבים להורות כי נתעלה
ללחום לחם אבירים. עוד עשב
הם ע״ב שמות[i] וראשי תיבותיו
הם ע״יקר ש״בינה ב״תחתונים
150 ושמות אלו יש מהם קדושים
נפלאים למעלה שהם סוד שפע
אילן עץ החיים הנק׳ תרומת
הקדשים ועליו נאמר מזריע
זרע למינהו. וכן קודם החטא
155 כתיב הנה נתתי לכם כל עשב
זורע זרע. אבל ואכלת את עשב
השדה לא נאמר בו זרע[ii] כי הוא
ע״ב שמות למטה שהם מתלבשים
בהנהגת מטטרון והם עשב השדה
160 התחתונים שהם מאכל בהמה
ועם כל זה אדם ובהמה תושיע
ה׳ כי עתה מתלבש בכתנות עור
בגשמי הגוף הזה ואוכל עשב
השדה. וזה נשפע בלי טורח
165 כל כך אבל סוד לחם מתבואה
עליונה שהיא שכינה המסתופפת
בספירות ופורשת סוכת שלום
עלינו והיא מעין נבואת מרע״ה
עליו נאמר בזיעת אפך תאכל
170 לחם ועליה נאמר כי לא יראני
האדם וחי. והנשמה הזוכה
אחר מיתתה מלחם אביה תאכל
הנקרא תרומת הקדשים אמנם
בעודה בגוף הזה כל תפלותיו
175 ותקוניו הם מקבלים ע״י העשב
השדה שהם בחות מזומנים לקבל
כל עסק תחתון להעלותו למעלה
והיינו ע״ב שמות תחתונים שהם

field lies the secret of the angels who are food for Malkhut [Kingdom], which comes from the side of the holy Chayot [living beings] called, in this aspect, "beast," and this grass is the nourishment and divine 145R
flow for the lower realms. Since the deceased has departed from the earthly nourishment symbolized by the "grass of the earth," which is food for his animal soul, we pluck the grass to indicate that he has been elevated to eat the "bread of the mighty" 150R
[Psalm 78:25].

Additionally, "grass" [עשב] refers to the 72 divine names, and its acronym is "the E"ssence of the S"hekhinah is in the L"ower realms.[1] Some of these names are wonderfully holy above, representing the 155R
flow from the Tree of Life, called the "offering of holy things," of which it is said "yielding seed according to its kind" [Genesis 1:12]. Similarly, before the sin, it is written, "Behold, I have given you every herb yielding seed" [Genesis 1:29]. But regarding "you 160R
shall eat the herb of the field" [Genesis 3:18], the word "seed" is not mentioned, because this refers to the 72 lower divine names clothed in the governance of Metatron, which are the "herbs of the field" of the lower realms that serve as food for beasts. Neverthe- 165R
less, "man and beast You save, O Lord" [Psalm 36:7], for now [after the sin] man is clothed in "garments of skin" in the physicality of this body and eats the herb of the field.

This flows without much effort, but the secret of 170R
bread from the higher grain—which is the Shekhinah [Divine Presence] that dwells among the sefirot [divine emanations] and spreads a tabernacle of peace over us, and is akin to the prophecy of Moses our teacher,[2] of whom it is said, "By the sweat of your 175R
brow shall you eat bread" [Genesis 3:19]—about this it is said, "For no man shall see Me and live" [Exodus 33:20]. The soul that merits, after its death, to eat of its Father's bread, called the "offering of holy

[1] I've preserved the unusual formatting of the original text with quotation marks to indicate that this is spelling out an acronym, where the first letters of each word form עשב (grass).
[2] The text establishes a hierarchy of prophetic experience, with Moses representing the highest level, described metaphorically as 'bread' rather than 'grass' or 'thorns,' indicating the most direct and substantial spiritual nourishment.

[i] The author employs a kabbalistic wordplay where the Hebrew word for grass (עשב) is connected to the 72-letter divine name (ע״ב שמות) through gematria (numerical equivalence) and as an acronym.
[ii] The author makes a distinction between pre-sin vegetation mentioned in Genesis 1:29 (which includes 'seed') and post-sin vegetation in Genesis 3:18 (which lacks mention of 'seed'). This absence is interpreted mystically as indicating a lower spiritual level.

סוד ההיכלות שכלם פתוחים
180 לדיני האדם ולכל מעשיו ויש
למטה מזה מדרגה שהיא מזדמנת
חנם תמיד לפני האדם וצריך
ליזהר ממנה מאד שהם החיצונים
הנקרא קוץ ודרדר הבאים
185 להכשיל האדם כנגד אלו יש שלש
מדרגות בנבואה. האחד טומאת
בלעם ולבן וכיוצא והנכנסים
בפרדס הנפגמין.[i] מדרגה שנייה
הנכנס ויוצא בשלום וכמה
190 מדרגות אלו ע״ג אלו עד סוד
הנבואה העליונה. הג׳ סוד לחם
שהוא מזון נפרץ פירוש נבואת
מרע״ה כדכתיב ביה קראן לו
ויאכל לחם ולהיות כי אחיזת
195 קוץ ודרדר וגם אכילת עשב
השדה אינו אלא עד שובך אל
האדמה זה יהיה טעם לשבח
לתלישת עשב השדה והשלכתן
לאחוריהן לסוד האחורים ומכאן
200 ולהבא מזון הנפטר יהיה מלחם
הקדשים לא מעשבי השדה עוד.
ועושין כן ג״פ לרמוז שנפש רוח
נשמה של הנפטר מתעלין למזון
העליון לחם ענ״ג:[ii]

things”—but while still in this body, all its prayers and spiritual rectifications are received through the “herb of the field,” which are forces prepared to receive all lower activities and elevate them. These are the 72 lower divine names, which are the secret of the palaces that are all open to man’s judgments and all his deeds. 180R 185R

Below this level is a degree that is always freely available before a person, but one must be very careful of it, for these are the external forces called “thorns and thistles” that come to cause a person to stumble. Corresponding to these, there are three levels in prophecy: First is the impurity of Balaam, Laban, and the like, and those who enter the “Pardes” [mystical realm] and are damaged. The second level is for one who enters and exits in peace, and there are many levels one above the other until the secret of the highest prophecy. The third is the secret of bread, which is abundant nourishment,[A] meaning the prophecy of Moses our teacher, as it is written about him, “Call him and let him eat bread” [Exodus 2:20]. 190R 195R 200R

Since the hold of “thorns and thistles” and even the eating of the “herb of the field” only lasts until “you return to the ground” [Genesis 3:19], this is the praiseworthy reason for plucking the grass of the field and throwing it behind them, symbolizing the “backside” [the realm of judgment], and from now on, the nourishment of the deceased will be from the “bread of holy things,” no longer from the herbs of the field. We do this three times to symbolize that the nefesh [vital soul], ruach [spirit], and neshamah [higher soul] of the deceased are elevated to 205R 210R

[A] Or: “unrestricted nourishment” — The Hebrew ‘nifratz’ implies breaking through boundaries or limitations, suggesting that Mosaic prophecy transcended normal prophetic limitations rather than simply being quantitatively abundant.

[i] This refers to the Talmudic story of the four sages who entered ‘Pardes’ (the mystical realm): Ben Azzai, Ben Zoma, Acher, and Rabbi Akiva. Only Rabbi Akiva emerged unharmed; the others were either damaged or died.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — This passage draws heavily on Zoharic concepts about the soul’s ascent after death, particularly the idea that the soul transitions from earthly nourishment to spiritual sustenance. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The text references the ‘Song of Afflictions’ (שיר של פגעים), which is the traditional rabbinic name for Psalm 91, used as protection against harmful spiritual forces particularly during funeral rites. | Cf. Genesis 3:17-19 — The passage reinterprets the curse of ‘eating herbs of the field’ and ‘by the sweat of your brow you shall eat bread’ as mystical references to different levels of spiritual nourishment available to humans. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok — This passage connects to earlier discussions in Ma’avar Yabok about how the soul transitions from physical to spiritual nourishment after death. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Shabbat 152b — The reference to Samuel speaking to Rav Yehudah about the dead not acknowledging God in Sheol comes from this Talmudic passage, which discusses how the dead forget the concerns of this world.

the higher nourishment, the bread of delight.[1]

פרק ל״א

בעמדנו על טעם המעמדות אשר הנהיגו חכמי הגמ׳ מלבד מ״ש נימוקי יוסף סוף פרק המוכר פירות בבתרא שהם כנגד שבעה דברים שהעולם נפסקין מהם בדכתיב זרע וקציר וקור וחום וקיץ וחורף ויום ולילה לא ישבותו ויום ולילה נחשבים אחד לומר כי החי יתן אל לבו כי העולם וכל ענייניו הבל. ואשרי מי שעמלו בתורה ובמעשים טובים. עוד אולי יהיה יען כי כח הדין נתגבר על המת שנהפכו עליו ההבלים עליונים קדושים ללהבים ואפי׳ מלאכי שלום בכו עליו פי׳ הורידו עליו דין[i] עד כי ירד למטה למקום שהדין יוצא מהכח אל הפועל מקום המיתה והכליון בסוד התכלת שמכלה הכל[ii] וירד מאיגרא רמא לבירא עמיקא שמאחר שבסוף ימיו קם ועלה והושפע ממדרגה השביעית ממטה למעלה שבהם

Chapter 31

In examining the meaning of the stations (ma'amadot) established by the Talmudic sages, beyond what Nimukei Yosef wrote at the end of chapter "The Seller of Fruits" in Bava Batra—that they correspond to the seven elements without which the world cannot exist,[A][2] as it is written: "Seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night shall not cease" (Genesis 8:22), with day and night counted as one—this teaches that the living should take to heart that the world and all its affairs are vanity. Fortunate is one whose labor is in Torah and good deeds.

Perhaps there is another reason: because the power of judgment intensified over the deceased, transforming the holy supernal breaths into flames.[B] Even the angels of peace wept over him—meaning they brought judgment upon him—until he descended to the place where judgment transitions from potential to actual, the place of death and extinction, in the mystery of the blue thread that consumes everything. He fell from a high roof into a deep pit,[C] for at the end of his days, he rose and was influenced by the seventh level from below

[A] Or: "from which the world derives sustenance" — The Hebrew literally refers to things 'from which the world is sustained/nourished.' While 'cannot exist without' captures the essential meaning, the alternate emphasizes the positive sustaining function rather than the negative consequence of their absence.

[B] Or: "when the holy supernal breaths were transformed into flames against him" — This alternative captures the directionality implied in 'עליו' (against him) more explicitly, emphasizing that these transformed breaths were directed specifically against the deceased as an expression of judgment.

[C] Or: "He descended from a lofty peak to a deep well" — This is a Talmudic expression (Chagigah 5b) referring to a dramatic descent or reversal of fortune. While 'roof' and 'pit' are literal translations, 'peak' and 'well' might better convey the metaphorical nature of the extreme transition being described.

[1] The Hebrew ענ״ג (delight) has a gematria value of 123, which in some kabbalistic systems connects to divine pleasure and the World to Come. This concludes the passage with the idea that the soul's ultimate nourishment after death is pure spiritual delight.

[2] This references Genesis 8:22, where God promises Noah that these natural cycles will never cease. The rabbis interpreted these seven phenomena as fundamental supports of creation, paralleling the seven 'breaths' (havalim) mentioned in Ecclesiastes that sustain the world.

[i] The author provides a mystical interpretation of angels' weeping: rather than expressing sorrow, their tears represent the flow of divine judgment upon the deceased.

[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the color tekhelet (ritual blue) represents divine judgment. The word 'mekhale' (consumes) forms a wordplay with 'tekhelet' (blue), connecting the color to its consuming/destructive function.

סוד והשפעת השבעים שנה והם
סדר זמני האדם ואמרו בזהר פ׳
בשלח שלכן בתיב ויזורר הילד
עד ז׳ פעמים ולא סליק יתיר
כד״א ימי שנותינו בהם שבעים
שנה. ולכן בכל תחלת עשר שנה
ובפרט משנת י״ג ומעלה האדם
נתוסף בו השפעה יתירה כדתנן
במשנה בן עשר שנים למשנה
בן עשרים לרדוף שהמדקדק
במשנה ההיא ימצא בה מוצא
רוח יתירה שזוכה האדם השלם
בסוף כל עשר שנים משנותיו
עד הגיעו לשנת השיבה כי אז
הוא שלם ומכובד בעיני אלהים
ואדם ונגד זקניו כבוד דכתיב
מפני שיבה תקום בקימה שיש
בה סדור ואפי׳ לזקני ע״ה.
ע״פ הדברים האלה צריך לתקן
מעשיו בכל חלק משנותיו להאיר
עליו הספירה שמשפעת עליו
בפרט בעשר שנים ראשונים
הוא מושפע ממלכות שרגליה
יורדת מות ולכן הקליפ׳ גוברת
עליו ובורח מן הספר בי׳ שנים
שניי׳ מושפע מיסוד ולכן אז
נושא אשה וישתדל לתקן הכנות
ליחוד ביסוד שהוא השושבין.
בשלישים צריך שיתאזר בכחו
נגד רתיחת הבחרות שכן הוד
מתחזקת בדין. ובבחינת האדם
מהות הספירה השופעת עליו ידע
מה יהיה עקר מציאותו לתקון
עליון ולקשוט נפשו והדרוש הזה
מתרחב מאליו. וממה שכתוב
בזהר פ׳ תצוה דף קפ״ד ע״א
נבין למה הדין מתעורר מסוד

upward,[1] which contains the mystery and influence of seventy years—the pattern of human life phases. 25R

They said in the Zohar, Parashat Beshalach, that this is why it is written: "The child sneezed seven times" (II Kings 4:35) and no more, as it is said: "The days of our years are seventy years" (Psalms 90:10). Therefore, at the beginning of each decade, 30R especially from age thirteen onward, additional divine influence is added to a person, as we learned in the Mishnah: "At ten years for Mishnah, at twenty to pursue,"[2] etc. One who examines that Mishnah carefully will find in it evidence of the additional spirit 35R that the complete person merits at the end of each decade of his life until reaching old age, when he becomes complete and honored in the eyes of God and man, "and before his elders, glory" (Isaiah 24:23). As it is written: "Before the aged you shall rise" (Leviticus 19:32)—with a rising that has order,[A] even for 40R the elders of the common people.

Based on these principles, one must rectify one's deeds in each period of life to draw upon oneself the divine emanation (sefirah) that influences one 45R at that time. Particularly in the first decade, one is influenced by Malkhut, whose "feet descend to death" (Proverbs 5:5), and therefore the negative forces dominate and one flees from learning. In the second decade, one is influenced by Yesod,[3] and thus 50R takes a wife and strives to prepare for unification through Yesod, which is the attendant. In the third decade, one must gird oneself against the heat of youth, as Hod intensifies in judgment. By understanding the nature of the sefirah influencing him, a 55R person will know what should be the essence of his existence for supernal rectification and the adornment of his soul. This subject expands naturally.

From what is written in the Zohar, Parashat Tetzaveh, page 184a, we understand why judgment is 60R

[A] Or: "with a formal rising" — The phrase suggests a dignified, properly structured form of rising rather than a casual one. 'Formal rising' might better capture the ritual aspect implied in the text about how one should show respect to elders.

[1] In kabbalistic thought, human development is understood as an ascent through the lower seven sefirot (divine emanations). The seventh and highest of these is associated with completion and judgment, which explains why at the end of life one encounters judgment.

[2] This references Pirkei Avot 5:21, which outlines appropriate activities for each stage of life. The author reinterprets this teaching through a kabbalistic lens, suggesting that each decade corresponds to influence from a different divine emanation (sefirah).

[3] Yesod (Foundation) is the divine attribute associated with sexuality and procreation in kabbalistic thought, explaining why it corresponds to marriage age. Each sefirah influences different decades of human life, guiding appropriate developmental activities.

עוה״ב הנקרא שביעי[i] וע״ש בדף קכ״א מסוד ימי שנותינו בהם שבעים שנה. ושם אמר שהעוה״ז נדון בדין התחתון כי לא היה יכול לסבול תוקף דין העליון על כן מדת הדין הרפה אלהי כל הארץ יקרא ופי׳ גם כן למה אין ב״ד עליון מעניש אלא מבן עשרים שנה ומעלה. ופעמים האדם זוכה ועולה למקום הגבורות עליונות ונקראות גבורות שמהם מתעוררים כחות הגבורות התחתונות שהם כמו העצים שהאור נדלק בהם ומתמן ואילך לית אתר לקיומי כ״כ. וכבר דברנו מזה למעלה. ועל ידי שבעה הבלים עליונים יושפע הבל וחיות לאדם עודנו חי ואמרו בתקון ס״ט כי הבל מסטרא דימינא כלול שבעה הבלים ואינון אבגית״ץ וכו׳[ii] ובמקום אחר אמר ששבעה שמות אלה הם במלכות ועולים בשש טבעות הקנה והבל הפה הוא השביעי. כנגדן אמר דוד שבעה קולות במזמור הבו לה׳ בני אלים כי התחתונים החיים כל כח ואל שלהם הוא משבעה הבלים אלו ונקראים מוצא פי ה׳ ושבעה קולות אלו עולים בשבעה רקיעים. ויש שבעה משמאל היורדים בשבעה ארצות ושבעה הבלים טובים הם ז׳ ימי השבוע ויש אחרים נגד שני הרעב ואלה הם הבלים דחיים ואלה הם הבלים דמות ויהיה כללותם ובחינתם לחסד ובחינתם לדין והמוציא שקרים

aroused from the mystery of the World to Come, which is called "the seventh." See also page 121 regarding the mystery of "The days of our years are seventy years." There it states that this world is judged by the lower judgment, for it could not bear the intensity of the higher judgment. Therefore, the milder attribute of judgment is called "God of all the earth," and it also explains why the heavenly court does not punish except from twenty years of age and upward.

Sometimes a person merits and ascends to the place of the higher Gevurot (Strengths), which are called "powers" from which the lower forces of Gevurah are awakened. These are like the wood in which fire is kindled, and from there onward, there is barely a place for existence. We have already discussed this above.

Through the seven supernal breaths, breath and vitality are bestowed upon a person while still alive. They said in Tikkun 69 that breath from the right side includes seven breaths, which are ABGITATZ, etc. Elsewhere it is said that these seven names are in Malkhut and ascend through the six rings of the windpipe, with the breath of the mouth being the seventh. Corresponding to these, David mentioned seven voices in the psalm "Ascribe to the Lord, O divine beings" (Psalm 29), for the living beings below derive all their power and divinity from these seven breaths, which are called "the utterance of the Lord's mouth." These seven voices ascend through the seven heavens.[1] There are also seven from the left side that descend through the seven earths. The seven good breaths correspond to the seven days of the week, while others correspond to years of famine. These are breaths of life, and those are breaths of death. Their totality and aspects relate to kindness (Chesed) and to judgment (Din).

One who speaks falsehoods—how many angels of

[1]The text presents a complex cosmology where seven breaths or emanations (havalim) from the right side (mercy) ascend through the heavens, while seven from the left side (judgment) descend through the earths. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that divine energy flows in both directions between upper and lower worlds.

[i]The author references the Zoharic teaching that the World to Come (seventh level) is the source of judgment, which seems paradoxical since the afterlife is typically associated with reward. This establishes the kabbalistic framework that links the number seven with both judgment and completion.

[ii]This refers to the first word of the 42-letter Divine Name, often used in kabbalistic meditation. The full Name consists of seven six-letter sequences, corresponding to the seven breaths (havalim) mentioned in Ecclesiastes.

מפיו כמה מלאכי חבלה פותחים
100 פיהם לקבל אותם וחבל לאותם
שנשבעים לשקר. עיין דף קי״ז
והאריך שם בסוד ההבלים הרבה
ואגב פירש דברים נחמדים ובדף
קי״ח קרא תגר על המנגנים
105 בהבלים ואמר דעלייהו אמרו
זמרא בביתא חרבא בסיפא. הנה
כי שבעה הבלים אלו מהם קיום
הכל וחיי האדם כמו שזכרנו
ובעודנו חי עולה עד האלהים
110 גבורה עליונה ופעמים עד ועד
בכלל: [i]

destruction open their mouths to receive them! Woe
to those who swear falsely. See page 117, where 100R
the mystery of the breaths is discussed at length,
and incidentally, pleasant matters are explained. On
page 118, he denounces those who play music with
breaths, saying that of them it is said: "Music in the
house leads to destruction in the end." Indeed, these 105R
seven breaths are the foundation of everything and of
human life, as we mentioned. While still alive, one
ascends to God, the supreme Gevurah, and some-
times even to the very limit.

פרק ל״ב

נאמר בתמימי דרך קריבה
בימיהם למיתה ומלבד הנדרש
בזה בזהר פ׳ ויחי ובשאר
מקומות לפי דרכנו נאמר
5 שקריבת הימים ירצה כי יורדים
למטה קרוב להנהגה התחתונה
הנקרא אחרית הימים בפ׳ תשא
והיא בית מועד לכל חי וכד
אחשכת נהורא ואתדבקת בחויא
10 בדין שאיבת מותא לכלא: וזהו
פי׳ בעטיו של נחש וכשהימים
קרבים ליה אז יגוע אדם ואיו

Chapter 32

It is said of those who walk blamelessly that their
days draw near to death. Beyond what is expounded
on this in the Zohar portion of Vayechi and in other
places, according to our approach we can say that
the "drawing near of days"[1] means they descend 5R
downward, close to the lower governance called "the
end of days"[A] in the portion of Ki Tisa, which is
"the house appointed for all living." And when the
light darkens and cleaves to the serpent, then death
draws everything to itself.[B] 10R

This is the meaning of "by the counsel of the
serpent,"[C] and when the days draw near to it, then

[A] Or: "means they descend toward the lower realm known as 'the end of days'" — This alternative simplifies the language while preserving the kabbalistic concept of descent to lower spiritual realms at death.

[B] Or: "And when the divine light dims and attaches to the serpent, then death absorbs everything" — This alternative emphasizes the divine nature of the light and uses 'absorbs' which might better capture the Aramaic 'sha'ivat' (drawing in/absorbing).

[C] Or: "due to the serpent's influence" — This alternative may be clearer to readers unfamiliar with the traditional rabbinic phrase.

[1] This mystical phrase refers to the approach of death, using the metaphor of days themselves approaching a spiritual boundary.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — The Zohar connects the seven sneezes of the child revived by Elisha (II Kings 4:35) to the seventy years of human lifespan (Psalms 90:10), suggesting that these seven breaths/emanations correspond to the cycles of human life. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Tetzaveh — This section of the Zohar explains why divine judgment is associated with the seventh level or World to Come, and why it manifests differently in this world than in higher realms. | Cf. Tikkun 69 of Tikkunei Zohar — This text explains that the seven breaths (havalim) correspond to the 42-letter divine name beginning with ABGITATZ, which are arranged in seven groups of six letters each. | Cf. Psalm 29 — The text connects the seven stations (ma'amadot) to the seven mentions of 'the voice of the Lord' in Psalm 29, suggesting that these correspond to the seven divine breaths that sustain creation. | Cf. Pirkei Avot 5:21 — The reference to 'ten years for Mishnah, twenty to pursue' alludes to the Mishnah in Pirkei Avot that outlines the appropriate activities for each stage of life, which the author reinterprets through a kabbalistic lens of sefirot corresponding to decades.

ומורידים אותו על ערש דוי
בהפך אותיות רעש ואש אוכלה
כנדרש בתקון י״ח דף ל״א ל״ב
ע״ב. ופי׳ כי החולה בא לחולה
מחמת הפוך רחמים לדין בסוד
היו״ד במלואה נהפכת לדו״י גם
יו״ד במספרה היא עשר והעשר
חזרו להיות ער״ש הרי כי כל
משכבו הפכת בחליו הוא סוד
שני הפכים. ורעש הוא מלכות
הכוללת עשר ספירות והיא רעש
ודאי מטתו שלשלמה. ויש לה
ג׳ בחינות שתים מן הימין ער״ש
עש״ר וב׳ מן האמצע שר״ע
ושע״ר. ויתבארו במקומן וב׳
מן השמאל הא׳ רע״ש ומצד דין
החזק שנפגמת מצד החצונים
נאמר עליה מקום המשפט שהיא
מקום לת״ת הנקרא משפט שם
הקליפות חצונות שהם רש״ע
והקדושים עליונים מתקנים
דיניה בכל יום וזהו ברעש גדול.
ובזהר פ׳ ויחי ובפ׳ בשלח דף
מ״ז ע״ב ובפ׳ תרומה דף קע״ד
שם פי׳ מיתה הנאמרת במשה
ואמר כי יעקב היה דבוק בעץ
החיים דלית ביה מותא לעלמין
ויהב חיין לכל אינון דמתדבקן
ביה ובעת גריעת הכחות שהיו לו
בחלק הנקרא ישראל שבבחינה
הנקרא יעקב אבינו לא מת
כדפי׳ החכם אלשיך אז אסף
רגליו פי׳ כל סבותיו ומקריו
שעברו עליו בעוה״ז למטה
שרגליה יורדות מות ובחינה
שסביבותיה שיתין פולסי דנורא
מגבורה עליונה: ובתקון כ״ד
פי׳ שכנגד ס׳ גבורים השומרים

"a person expires and where is he?"[1] They lower him onto a sickbed, which inverts the letters of "tumult" (רעש) and "consuming fire" (אש אוכלה), as expounded in Tikkun 18, pages 31-32b. The explanation is that the sick person becomes ill due to the transformation of mercy into judgment,[2] in the mystery of the fully spelled letter Yod being transformed into "illness" (דוי). Also, the numerical value of Yod is ten, and these ten are transformed into "bed" (ערש). Thus, "You have transformed his entire bed in his illness" refers to the mystery of two inversions.[3] And "tumult" (רעש) is Malkhut, which encompasses ten sefirot, and it is indeed the "tumult" of "Solomon's bed."[4] It has three aspects: two from the right side—"bed" (ערש) and "wealth" (עשר); two from the middle—"evil" (שרע) and "gate" (שער), which will be explained in their proper place; and two from the left side, the first being "tumult" (רעש). From the aspect of strong judgment that is damaged by external forces, it is said of Malkhut, "the place of judgment"—for it is the place of Tiferet, which is called "judgment." There, the external shells are "wicked" (רשע), and the supernal holy ones rectify her judgments every day, and this is "with a great tumult."

In the Zohar portions of Vayechi and Beshalach (page 47b) and Terumah (page 174), the death mentioned regarding Moses is explained. It states that Jacob was attached to the Tree of Life,[5] in which there is no death for all eternity, and it gives life to all who cleave to it. At the time when the powers he possessed in the aspect called "Israel" were diminished—though in the aspect called "Jacob our father did not die," as explained by the sage Alshich—then "he gathered his feet," meaning all his circumstances and events that had transpired for him in this lower world, where "her feet descend to death," and the aspect surrounding her is sixty lashes of fire[A] from

15R 20R 25R 30R 35R 40R 45R 50R

[A] Or: "sixty measures of fiery judgment" — This alternative better captures the mystical concept

[1] This is a reference to Job 14:10, using biblical language to emphasize the mystery of what happens after death.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, illness and death occur when divine mercy (rachamim) is transformed into judgment (din), representing a shift in divine attributes affecting the human condition.

[3] The author is using letter permutation techniques common in kabbalah, showing how Hebrew words can be rearranged to reveal deeper spiritual meanings about illness and death.

[4] The author creates a complex wordplay connecting the Hebrew word for 'tumult' (ra'ash) with Malkhut (divine kingdom) and the biblical reference to Solomon's bed guarded by sixty warriors.

[5] The author presents a mystical interpretation of Jacob's biblical status, suggesting he achieved a spiritual level connected to the kabbalistic Tree of Life that transcends ordinary death.

המטה התחתונה יש ס׳ מלכות
אלו זכרים ואלו נקבות בית
קבול לאלו ושיתין פולסי דנורא
אלו עם עשרה דידה נחתו
מסטרא דאימא עילאה ומאן
דאתדבק למטה בעלמא דנוקבא
מיתה אזדמנת קמיה כדאמרי׳
על חבקוק בנה של שונמית
דאצטריך אלישע לאתערא רוחא
מלעילא ואתקשר באתר דהוה
ואתיב ליה נפשיה בכח רי״ו
אותיות: על כן הנקבות עליהן
מוטל המצוה ראשונה להתעסק
בצרכי המת להכין ליה זוודתא
מלבד מה שאמרו במדרש ב״ר פ׳
ט״ז שהולכות אצל המת תחלה
על ידי שגרמו מיתה לעולם.
עוד לפי דרכנו נאמר שכן אשת
חיל בטח בה לב בעלה ועושה
בחפץ כפיה להכין בגדי מלכות
לבעלה מכח מעשים והתעוררות
התחתונים כי צו לצו פי׳ מכל
מצוה ומצוה קו לקו נארגים
חוטים וקוים ללבושי יקר ומהן
המעורר מטל חלקו וכן אמר
שלמה בחכמתו נודע בשערים
בעלה ירצה שמסבת לבושים
היקרים שהתקינה לנגדו ולו
אשת חיל נודע וניכר שמידה
באו לו ובזה מתעלה לישב
בשובה ונחת עם זקני ארץ בחינת
שלש ראשונות כי עשתה בחפץ
כפיה בחכמת הפלך שהיא חכמה
מיוחדת לה לארוג מהשפעות
העליונות היורדות מכח מעשים

supernal Gevurah.

In Tikkun 24, it explains that corresponding to the sixty mighty ones who guard the lower bed,[A1] there are sixty Malkhuts—these are male and these are female, a receptacle for those. 55R
And these sixty lashes of fire, together with her ten, descend from the side of the Supernal Mother.[2] Whoever cleaves below to the feminine realm, death is prepared before him, as we say regarding Habakkuk, the son of the Shunammite 60R
woman, for whom Elisha needed to awaken a spirit from above[B] and connect it to the place where it had been, and restored his soul to him through the power of the 216 letters.

Therefore, it is incumbent upon women to fulfill 65R
the first commandment of attending to the needs of the deceased, to prepare provisions for him,[C] besides what is said in the Midrash Bereishit Rabbah, chapter 16, that they go to the deceased first because they brought death into the world. Furthermore, ac- 70R
cording to our approach, we can say that just as "a woman of valor—her husband's heart trusts in her," and she willingly works with her hands to prepare royal garments for her husband through the power of deeds and the awakening from below, for "precept 75R
upon precept" means that from each and every commandment, "line upon line," threads and lines are woven for precious garments, and from these awakens the dew of his portion.[3] Thus Solomon said in his wisdom, "Her husband is known in the gates," 80R
meaning that because of the precious garments she prepared for him, this woman of valor, it is known and evident that they came from her, and through this he is elevated to sit in tranquility and contentment with the elders of the land, in the aspect of the 85R

of divine judgment being measured out in specific quantities.

[A] Or: "the sixty warriors who protect the lower divine couch" — This alternative makes more explicit the divine/mystical nature of the 'bed' being referenced.

[B] Or: "for whom Elisha had to arouse the supernal life-force" — This alternative more clearly conveys the mystical concept of drawing down divine life energy to restore life.

[C] Or: "to prepare spiritual provisions for his journey" — This alternative makes explicit the metaphorical meaning of 'provisions' as spiritual preparations for the soul's journey after death.

[1] This continues the interpretation of Song of Songs 3:7, where the sixty warriors are understood as spiritual forces protecting the divine feminine presence (Malkhut).

[2] This refers to Binah (Understanding), the third sefirah, which is characterized in kabbalah as the 'Supernal Mother' from which divine judgment emanates.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'tal' (dew), representing divine life-force or spiritual sustenance that nourishes the soul.

מהם אורגת בגדים נאים לבניה.
וכן הפלך הוא הורדת השפע ע״י
שפתותיה שהם שושנים עליונים
מהצמר העליון דכתיב ושער
רישיה כעמר נקי שהם סוד
השערות שבהם תקוני ושרשי
התחתונים בסוד התפשטות
השערות ולכן הבעל כופה אשתו
לעשות בצמר כי בשהיא בטלה
מסוד ההשפעה מביאה העולם
לידי שעמום ממהומת המבטלים
היחוד ח״ו ואפי׳ הכניסה לו
כמה עבדים שגם שמלה מתלבשת
במטטרו״ן וסנדלפון שהם עבד
ואמה ויש עוד למעלה מאלו
בחינת עבד עברי מ״מ עיקר
הנהגת התחתונים הוא על
ידה ובחינת אלו הם לבושים
המעלמים שפעה כדי שיוכל
העולם לסובלו. הנה כי על
הנשים תחלה להתעסק בצרכי
המת. ויבינו לו תבריכיו ראשון
ראשון מלמטה למעלה והחלוק
הסמוך לבשרו קודם לכל ואח״כ
הבתי שוקים וכן בהדרגה. וסוד
התפירה הוא במטטרון בחינת
אופן שמלכות נקבה מקננת בו
ושם נארגים החלוקה דרבנן וגם
לבושי מלכות לעלות למעלה
ולכן עליהן המצוה הזאת ואחר
שעשו לו הנקבות תקון המתייחס
להן ולבחינתן באים האנשים
על הנשים ומעלין אותו בכח
הרחיצה וטהרה שהיא הבנה
לקדושה בסוד וטהרו וקדשו
ובה ובכחה מסתלק מעלמא

three highest sefirot,[1] for she worked willingly with her hands in the wisdom of the spindle,[A] which is a wisdom unique to her, to weave from the supernal influences that descend through the power of deeds, from which she weaves beautiful garments for her children. 90R

Similarly, the spindle represents the bringing down of divine flow through her lips, which are supernal roses, from the supernal wool, as it is written, "and the hair of His head was like pure wool," which is the mystery of the hairs in which are the rectifications and roots of the lower realms, in the mystery of the extension of the hairs. Therefore, the husband compels his wife to work with wool, for when she is idle from the mystery of influence, she brings the world to desolation from the confusion of those who nullify unification, God forbid. Even if she brought him many servants—for even "garment" (שמלה) is clothed in Metatron and Sandalphon,[2] who are servant and maidservant, and there is even above these the aspect of a Hebrew servant—nevertheless, the primary governance of the lower realms is through her, and these aspects are garments that conceal her influence so that the world can bear it.[B] 95R 100R 105R

Thus, it is incumbent upon women first to attend to the needs of the deceased. They prepare his shrouds, first the lowest and then ascending, with the garment closest to his flesh coming before all, and afterward the leg coverings, and so on in gradual steps. The mystery of the sewing is in Metatron, the aspect of the Ofan (angelic wheel) in which the female Malkhut nests, and there the scholarly garments are woven,[3] as well as the garments of Malkhut to ascend upward. Therefore, this commandment is upon them. After the women have performed the rectification appropriate to them and their aspect, the men 110R 115R 120R

[A] Or: "the mystical art of the distaff" — This alternative emphasizes the esoteric nature of the spinning metaphor being used.

[B] Or: "and these dimensions serve as veils that moderate her divine flow so the world can endure it" — This alternative more clearly conveys the kabbalistic concept of divine energy being 'veiled' or moderated through various levels to be receivable by lower realms.

[1] The author equates the biblical 'elders' with the three highest divine emanations (Keter, Chokhmah, and Binah), suggesting that proper spiritual practice elevates one to these sublime levels.

[2] The author is making a kabbalistic wordplay, suggesting that the Hebrew word for 'garment' relates to these angelic beings who themselves serve as 'garments' or intermediaries for divine energy.

[3] This refers to the mystical concept of 'chaluqa d'rabbanan' (the scholarly garment), which is the spiritual vestment created by one's Torah study that clothes the soul in the afterlife.

דנוקבא אשר ירד לשם במיתתו
ועולה לעלמא דדכורא: וטוב
ליתן הדס ושושנים ואזוב במים
ושם מתקנים בחינות נשמתו
ורוחו ונפשו בהלביש אותם בגדי
ישע אחר שהפשיטו מעליו בגדי
בדדין שהוא הסדין שהיה בתוכו
והזוהמא אשר היתה דבוקה
בבשרו כאשר יבא הכל מפורש
בחלק ג׳ מדרושנו זה אשר יקרא
שפתי רננות בעה״י: [i]

come after the women and elevate him through the power of washing and purification, which is preparation for holiness, in the mystery of "and they shall purify and sanctify."[1] Through this and its power, he departs from the feminine realm to which he descended in his death and ascends to the masculine realm.[2]

It is good to place myrtle, roses, and hyssop in the water, and there the aspects of his neshamah, ruach, and nefesh are rectified by clothing them in garments of salvation[A] after removing from him the garments of isolation,[3] which is the sheet in which he was wrapped, and the impurity that was attached to his flesh, all of which will be explained in detail in Part 3 of our discourse, which will be called "Lips of Joyous Song," with God's help.

פרק ל״ג

Chapter 33

[A] Or: "vestments of divine deliverance" — This alternative emphasizes the divine and salvific nature of these metaphysical garments that clothe the soul.

[1] This phrase references ritual purification concepts from the Temple service, applied here to the spiritual cleansing of the deceased.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, the feminine realm (alma d'nukva) is associated with physical existence and death, while the masculine realm (alma d'dikhura) represents spiritual elevation and life.

[3] The Hebrew term 'bigdei badadin' refers to the shroud or winding sheet in which the body was wrapped, metaphorically described as garments of separation or isolation.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Portion Vayechi — The Zohar passage elaborates on the mystical interpretation of Jacob's death, suggesting that true tzaddikim (righteous ones) like Jacob don't actually die in the conventional sense but rather transition to a higher spiritual existence. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This section of Tikkunei Zohar explores kabbalistic letter combinations and their spiritual meanings, particularly how the transformation of letters corresponds to shifts between divine mercy and judgment that manifest as illness in the physical world. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part 3 'Siftei Renanot' — The author references his own work, indicating that more detailed instructions on tahara (ritual washing of the deceased) will be provided in a later section called 'Lips of Joyous Song.' | Cf. Midrash Bereishit Rabbah — This midrash explains that women attend to the deceased first because Eve brought death into the world through the sin of eating from the Tree of Knowledge, establishing a theological basis for women's traditional role in preparing bodies for burial. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:7-8 — The text reinterprets this biblical verse in kabbalistic terms, with Solomon's bed representing the divine feminine presence (Malkhut) and the sixty warriors corresponding to spiritual forces that protect it. | Cf. 2 Kings 4:8-37 — The text references this biblical narrative as an example of death being a descent into the feminine realm, requiring spiritual intervention (in this case by the prophet Elisha) to return the soul to the body. | Cf. Proverbs 31:10-31 — The author draws upon this biblical passage about the 'woman of valor' (eshet chayil) and reinterprets it kabbalistically to explain women's spiritual role in preparing garments for the deceased, comparing it to their traditional role in creating physical garments. | Cf. Zohar, Portion Beshalach — This Zohar passage elaborates on the concept that those who cleave to the Tree of Life do not experience death in the conventional sense, which is applied in this text to explain Jacob's spiritual status. | Cf. Zohar, Portion Terumah — This passage from the Zohar compares Moses' death to Jacob's, exploring the different spiritual levels they achieved and how these affected their experience of death and transition. | Cf. Daniel 7:9 — The reference to 'hair of His head was like pure wool' alludes to this biblical description of the divine presence, which in kabbalistic interpretation represents channels for divine energy flowing from higher to lower realms.

הדרן למאי דפתחנא ביה ליתן טעם לשבע ישיבות והוא כי יען שלצורך תקון הנפטר הוצרכנו לירד בבשתנו למעה עד המקום אשר הודח שם להעלותו אח״כ בכח החסד של אמת שעשינו עמו נעשה ז׳ ישיבות וז׳ מעמדות וחרב פיפיות בפינו בשיר של פגעים המבריח הרוחות מכל מקום שהן.[i] אמרו כי יש מוצא מהרבה מהם מתחת לארץ ומהם בארץ עצמה ומהם באויר הקרוב אלינו הנקראים שרי רוח. ובן בכל הארבע יסודות ומהם למעלה עד גלגל הירח ובן בכל הגלגלים ומוצא כולם מהשרים והקליפות רוכבי הגלגלים שהם חלק העשיה גשמית. ובשיר זה עם ישיבות אלו סוקלים המסלה כי הוא זמיר עריצים ומסירים אותם מעלינו במלין דזמרא אינון חיצים לגבי חויא בישא ס״מ[ii] וזהו עד יפלח חץ כבדו דתמן ס״מ יסודיה ועקריה בג״פ הכבד כועס ובמא כועס במר׳ נוקבא דיליה זנבא דיליה דבתר דעבידת ניאופין יהיבת שיורין לבעלה במרה כעיס ובזנבא דהיא יותרת קטיל בדדרש בתקון י״ג דף כ״ה[iii] ובכח חיצים אלו אנו עולים הלוך ונסוע מהבל התחתון בדדרש ההוא מארי דקבין בתקונים עד הנגבה. ובכל ישיבה ועכבה

We return to what we began with, to provide a reason for the seven stations [during the funeral procession],[1] which is because for the rectification of the deceased, we needed to descend in our shame to the place where he was expelled, in order to later elevate him through the power of true kindness that we performed for him. We establish seven stations and seven sittings, with a double-edged sword in our mouths in the form of the "Song of Afflictions"[2] [Psalm 91] which drives away harmful spirits from wherever they may be.[3] It is said that many of these spirits emanate from beneath the earth, some from the earth itself, and some from the air close to us, called "princes of the wind." Similarly, they exist in all four elements, and some reach upward to the sphere of the moon and through all the celestial spheres, with their source being the celestial princes and negative forces that ride the spheres, which are part of the physical realm of Action (Asiyah).[4]

With this psalm and these stations, we clear the path, for it prunes the powerful [negative forces] and removes them from us. These words of song are like arrows against the evil serpent Samael, as it is written: "until an arrow pierces his liver"—for there Samael has his foundation and root. The liver becomes angry in three ways, and with what does it become angry? With the gall of his female counterpart, his tail, for after she commits adultery, she gives the remnants to her husband. Through the gall he becomes angry, and through the tail, which is the lobe, he kills, as explained in Tikkun 13, page 25. Through the power of these arrows, we ascend, journeying from the lower realm, as explained by

[1]The Hebrew text uses the term 'seven sittings' (שבע ישיבות), referring to a now largely obsolete Jewish mourning custom where the funeral procession would stop seven times between the home and the cemetery.

[2]I've placed Psalm 91 in brackets to clarify which psalm is being referenced. This psalm is traditionally called 'Shir Shel Pega'im' and was recited for protection against harmful spirits.

[3]The text reflects the kabbalistic belief that reciting Psalm 91 creates a protective shield against negative spiritual forces that might interfere with the soul's peaceful transition.

[4]In Kabbalah, Asiyah is the lowest of four spiritual worlds, closest to physical reality. The text describes a cosmology where negative forces inhabit different levels of creation.

[i]This phrase refers to Psalm 91, traditionally known as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons), which was believed to have special protective powers against harmful spiritual forces.

[ii]S"M refers to Samael, a name used in Jewish mystical texts to refer to the Angel of Death or the chief of evil spirits.

[iii]This references Tikkun 13, page 25 of Tikkunei Zohar, a major kabbalistic text.

עם כח שירי זמרה שבפינו אנו
מתעלים מעלה עד אהבה רבה
שהוא חסד לאברהם. ובכן
אך טוב וחסד ירדפונו כל
ימי חיינו. ותאנא בצניעותא
דספרא[i] דחסדא עילאה בכלא
אצטריך לאתרברבא ולמיבני
ליה ולא לקטעא ליה ח״ו ואין
לישראל להשחית זקנם בתער
ויש פרושים מחמירים אפילו
במספרים כעין תער ועיין
באדרת נשא בתקון ששי מי״ג
תקוני דיקנא יקירא.[ii] וסדר
עליית מעלמא דנוקבא מל׳
עד חסד[iii] נרמז בפסוק כי
מלאכיו יצוה לך לשמרך בכל
דרכיך[iv] שמלבד שהוא שבע
תיבות עוד בכל תיבה ממנו
נרשם סדר עליות אלו ולעולם
העליון כולל מה שלמטה ממנו
עמו ונכלל בו בחות קדושים
משפיעים ומקבלים המתייחדים
על ידי יסוד הנקרא כל. וכל
המזמור הוא מצד ספירת הוד
להשבית מעול וחומץ. ולכן החזן
היה אומר שבו יקרים שבו עמדו
יקרים עמודו להראות כוונתם
שהוא לעלות עד מדת החסד על
דרך מה יקר חסדך אלהים. עוד
ההקפות הנעשים למת מלבד
מה שאנו עתידים לדרוש בהם
יהיה כדי להשפיע עליו קדושה
מז׳ ימים עליונים ולהבריח

the master of measures in the Tikkunim, toward the south [symbolic of divine love]. With each station and pause, with the power of song in our mouths,[1] we elevate ourselves higher until reaching the great love, which is loving-kindness for Abraham.[2] Thus, "surely goodness and kindness shall follow us all the days of our lives."

It is taught in the Book of Concealment that supernal kindness needs to be magnified and built up in all things, not cut off, God forbid. Therefore, Israel should not destroy their beards with a razor, and there are strict interpreters who forbid even scissors that cut like a razor. See the Idra of Naso, in the sixth of the thirteen arrangements of the precious beard.[3]

The order of ascent from the feminine realm (Malkhut) to loving-kindness (Chesed) is alluded to in the verse: "For He will command His angels concerning you, to guard you in all your ways." Besides containing seven words, in each word is inscribed the order of these ascents, and the higher world always includes what is below it and incorporates holy powers that influence and receive, unifying through the foundation called "all." The entire psalm relates to the divine attribute of Hod, to eliminate oppression and violence. Therefore, the cantor would say: "Sit, precious ones, sit; stand, precious ones, stand"—to show their intention to ascend to the attribute of loving-kindness, in the manner of "How precious is Your loving-kindness, O God."

Furthermore, the circuits made around the deceased, besides what we will explain about them

[1] The Hebrew uses poetic language comparing psalms and prayers to weapons ('arrows' and a 'double-edged sword') that combat spiritual forces, reflecting the kabbalistic view that properly intoned sacred words have actual metaphysical effects.

[2] The text associates Abraham with the divine attribute of Chesed (Loving-kindness), following traditional kabbalistic correspondences between the biblical patriarchs and specific divine attributes.

[3] In Kabbalah, the divine 'beard' (dikna) is a metaphor for channels of divine mercy flowing from higher spiritual realms to lower ones. The prohibition against shaving is connected to this mystical concept.

[i] This refers to Sifra D'Tzniuta ('Book of Concealment'), a section of the Zohar that contains highly esoteric kabbalistic teachings.

[ii] This refers to the 'Thirteen Arrangements of the Precious Beard,' a kabbalistic concept describing thirteen channels through which divine mercy flows into the world, metaphorically depicted as strands of a beard.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic ascent from Malkhut (Kingdom, the lowest sefirah, associated with the feminine) to Chesed (Loving-kindness, a higher sefirah).

[iv] This is a verse from Psalm 91:11, which is particularly significant as it comes from the same psalm ('Song of Afflictions') mentioned earlier in the text.

ממנו כחות החצונים שבז׳
היכלות התמורה בסוד ההיקף
והמחול שהוא בנצח הנוצח כל
אויב ומתנקם וסוד המחול הוא
העגול דהיינו סוד שש קצוות
שכלם משפיעים במלכות בסוד
גלגולם זה אחר זה והיא מקבלת
מכלם וזהו יהללו שמו במחול
והכוונה בהקפה תהיה להשפיע
במלכות שהיא אם ונשמת כל חי
מיומין עילאין כדאמרי׳ בפ׳
תצוה בדרוש ספירת העומר
ושם דף קכ״א בדרוש רמז ימי
הסוכה ובהקפת המזבח ובזה
היא מתוקנת מלמעלה ומקושטת
מלמטה מז׳ הנערות דאינון ז׳
היכלין בז׳ מושבות ומעמדות
שכן ההיכלות פעמים עומדים
לקבל ולהתאחד בקדש הקדשים
וזהו סמיכת גאולה קדש הקדשים
לתפלה הם שש היכלות תחתונים
ופעמים יושבים להשפיע.
ובתקון ו׳ דף י״ח פירשו כי
ההקפות הם בסוד נקבה תסובב
גבר[i] במשנה שהיא ששה סדרים
ומקפת לתורה שבכתב שהיא ה׳
חומשים. ולכן סובבים בארבעה
מינים המזבח שהוא רמז לגן
הנטועים בו וגן עם שבעה ימים
הם ששים כנגד ששים מסכתות.
ובשמיני עצרת בו שפע התורה
להשקות האילן הנטוע בגן
ולכן תאות ביום ההוא לשמחת
תורה וחוגגים במחול ובמחוג
בב״ה בסוד נעוץ הסוף בראש
וראש בסוף שכן הוא חק וסדר
המחול וכן מסיימים התורה וגם
מתחילים אותה ובו ביום ותחלת
ברכותיהם של ישראל והוא
שמחת גמר היחוד המתחילים
תקוניו מיום ראש השנה ונגמרים
קו לקו עד יום שמיני עצרת כי

later, are meant to bestow upon him holiness from the seven supernal days and to drive away from him the external forces of the seven palaces of exchange.[1] This is through the mystery of the circuit and the dance, which is in Netzach that conquers every enemy and avenger. The secret of the dance is the circle, meaning the secret of the six extremities [directions] that all influence Malkhut through their circular rotation one after another, and she receives from them all. This is the meaning of "Let them praise His name in dance." The intention in the circuit is to influence Malkhut, which is the mother and soul of all living, from the supernal days, as explained in Parashat Tetzaveh in the discourse on counting the Omer, and there on page 121 in the discourse alluding to the days of Sukkot and the circling of the altar. Through this, she is prepared from above and adorned from below by the seven maidens, which are the seven palaces, through the seven stations and sittings. For sometimes the palaces stand to receive and unite with the Holy of Holies—and this is the joining of redemption [the blessing after Shema] to prayer [the Amidah]—they are the six lower palaces; and sometimes they sit to bestow influence.

In Tikkun 6, page 18, it is explained that the circuits are in the mystery of "a woman shall encompass a man"—in the Mishnah, which has six orders and encompasses the Written Torah, which has five books. Therefore, we circle the altar with the four species, which alludes to the garden in which they are planted. And the garden with the seven days equals sixty, corresponding to the sixty tractates [of the Mishnah]. On Shemini Atzeret, the flow of Torah waters the tree planted in the garden, and therefore you will desire on that day to rejoice in the Torah and celebrate with dance and circle in the synagogue, in the mystery of "the end is wedged in the beginning and the beginning in the end," for such is the law and order of the dance. Thus, they complete the Torah and also begin it on that same day, the beginning of the blessings of Israel, and it is the joy of com-

[1] The 'palaces of exchange' (היכלות התמורה) in Kabbalah refer to realms dominated by negative forces that are counterparts to the holy palaces. The funeral rituals are meant to protect the deceased from these realms.

[i] This phrase ('a woman shall encompass a man') comes from Jeremiah 31:22 and is interpreted kabbalistically to signify times when the feminine aspect (Malkhut) surrounds and protects the masculine aspect.

110 אז הדודים עילאים הם בדביקתא ברעותא באחדוותא חדא[i] וה׳ אחד ושמו אחד:[ii]

pleting the unification that begins its rectifications from Rosh Hashanah and is completed line by line until Shemini Atzeret, for then the supernal lovers are in attachment, in willingness, in singular unity, and "the LORD is One and His name is One."[1] 110R

פרק ל״ד

Chapter 34

תנחומי אבלים הוא עקר גדול בג״ח ואמרו במדבר רבה פ״ח שהקב״ה מראה פנים לאבל. ונחם אברהם ויעקב תנחומי
5 אבלים וכן ביצחק כתיב ויהי אחרי מות אברהם ויברך אלהים את יצחק בנו וביעקב נאמר ויקומו כל בניו וכל בנותיו לנחמו. ועיין בפרקי ר׳ אליעזר
10 פרק י״ח משכר מצוה זו ומכמה מקומות למדנו זה וב׳ שערים היו בבית המקדש אחד לחתנים ואחד לאבלים[iii] ומה שתקנו אחר חורבן הבית בזה. ויזהר
15 האדם בנחמו שלא יהא ח״ו גידוף כדאמרי׳ פ׳ שור שנגח

Comforting mourners is a fundamental principle in acts of loving-kindness.[A] It is said in Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah, chapter 8, that the Holy One, blessed be He, shows His countenance to the mourner. Abraham and Jacob were comforted as mourners, and similarly with Isaac it is written: "And it came to pass after the death of Abraham that God blessed Isaac his son." Regarding Jacob it states: "And all his sons and all his daughters rose up to comfort him." See also Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer, chapter 18, concerning the reward for this commandment. We have learned this from many sources, and there were two gates in the Temple—one for bridegrooms and one for mourners—and what was instituted after the destruction of the Temple in this regard. 5R 10R 15R

[A] Or: "Consoling mourners is a major foundation of charitable deeds" — This alternative translation uses 'consoling' instead of 'comforting' and 'charitable deeds' instead of 'acts of loving-kindness,' which might be more accessible to readers unfamiliar with Jewish terminology. However, 'acts of loving-kindness' better captures the specific religious concept of gemilut chasadim.

[1] This closing phrase comes from Zechariah 14:9 and is also found in the Aleinu prayer. It expresses the ultimate kabbalistic goal of complete divine unity where all apparent divisions are reconciled.

[i] These Aramaic terms describe the highest state of mystical union: 'in attachment, in willingness, in singular unity'—referring to the complete unification of divine energies.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 91 — Psalm 91 is presented as having specific metaphysical effects when recited during the funeral process, creating a protective shield around both the deceased and the mourners against negative spiritual forces that might interfere with the soul's transition. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author draws on the Tikkunei Zohar to explain the mystical anatomy of negative forces, specifically how anger manifests through the liver, which is associated with Samael. This shows how Ma'avar Yabok integrates technical kabbalistic concepts from earlier authoritative sources. | Cf. Idra of Naso — The author connects practical Jewish law (not shaving with a razor) to its mystical significance as explained in the Zohar, demonstrating how Ma'avar Yabok explains ritual practices through their kabbalistic meaning. | Cf. Book of Concealment (Sifra D'Tzniuta) — The author draws on one of the most esoteric sections of the Zohar to support the idea that spiritual practices should expand divine mercy rather than restrict it, providing a theoretical basis for the funeral rituals described. | Cf. Zechariah 14:9 — This biblical reference frames the entire funeral ritual as ultimately serving the purpose of divine unification (yichud), a central concept in Kabbalah. The mourning practices are thus portrayed as contributing to cosmic harmony and the restoration of divine unity.

[iii] According to the Talmud (Mo'ed Katan 27b), there were two gates in the ancient Temple in Jerusalem—one for bridegrooms and one for mourners. On Sabbaths, people would gather there to congratulate the bridegrooms or comfort the mourners. This practice symbolized the Jewish community's responsibility to participate in both the joys and sorrows of its members.

מאי אית ליה לגבי נחמתא דבבלאי[i] וכו׳ ויזהרו שלא יבכה על מתו יותר מדאי[ii] פן יתריס נגד מדת הדין בנראה ממעשים בפ׳ אלו מגלחין. והנחמה היא גמילות חסדים גם לנפטר כדגרסינן במס׳ שבת מי שאין לו מנחמין הולכין עשרה בני אדם ויושבין במקומו וכן נראה ממעשה שאירע לר׳ יהודה שם. ויפתח האבל תחילה[iii] כדאמרינן בסוף פרק מציאת האשה. ויאמר דברי נחמות נגד האבלים ודברי שבח נגד המנחמין ולכל ישראל כדגרסינן במ״ק ובכתובות בר״ל עם מקרי בניה דא״ל קום אימא מלתא וכו׳ ואל יכנס א׳ לדברי חבירו ובפרט אם הוא חכם כדחזינן במיתת בניו של רבי ישמעאל. והאבל יודה למספידים ולמנחמים על הכבוד שעשו לו ויפטרם בשלום שראינו שר״ע עמד על ספסל גדול ופטר ישראל לשלום שהספידו בניו הספד גדול. ובשלשת רעי איוב כתיב לנוד לו ולנחמו[iv] מלת לנוד תורה לנו כי הנחמה מעלה האבל ומנידו ממקום השפעת הדין למקום נייחא ותנחומין כמו שכתוב ויעבר אלהים רוח

A person should be careful when offering comfort that it not become, God forbid, blasphemous, as stated in the chapter "An Ox That Gored":[1] "What benefit is there in the consolation of the Babylonians?" etc. One should also be careful not to weep excessively over one's dead, lest one protest against the attribute of divine judgment, as evident from incidents in the chapter "These May Shave." 20R

This comfort is an act of kindness also for the deceased, as we learn in Tractate Shabbat: "For one who has no comforters, ten people go and sit in his place," as appears from the incident that happened to Rabbi Judah there. The mourner should speak first,[2] as stated at the end of the chapter "Finding a Wife." He should speak words of comfort to the mourners and words of praise for the comforters and for all Israel, as we learn in Mo'ed Katan and Ketubot about Resh Lakish with the teachers of his children, when he said to him, "Rise and say something," etc. One should not interrupt another's words, especially if he is a sage, as we see in the case of the death of Rabbi Ishmael's sons. The mourner should thank those who eulogize and comfort him for the honor they have shown him, and dismiss them in peace, as we saw that Rabbi Akiva stood on a large bench and dismissed the Israelites in peace after they had greatly eulogized his sons. 25R 30R 35R 40R

Regarding Job's three friends, it is written "to mourn with him and to comfort him." The word "to mourn" teaches us that comforting elevates the 45R

[1] This references a Talmudic passage (Bava Kamma 38a) where inappropriate consolation is criticized. The Hebrew term 'גידוף' (giduf) implies blasphemy or insulting God, suggesting that improper consolation can actually be spiritually harmful rather than helpful.

[2] This follows the principle established in Talmud Bava Metzia 59b that visitors should not speak to a mourner until the mourner speaks first. This practice respects the mourner's emotional state and acknowledges their primary position in the mourning process.

[i] This refers to an incident in the Talmud (Bava Kamma 38a) where inappropriate consolation was offered. The Babylonians offered consolation by saying 'What can be done?' which implied helplessness against divine judgment. This teaches that consolation should not suggest resignation to fate but should provide genuine comfort.

[ii] The Talmud (Mo'ed Katan 27b) establishes limits on mourning, stating that one should not mourn excessively. Excessive mourning was seen as questioning divine judgment and potentially harmful to the mourner's own spiritual and physical wellbeing.

[iii] This follows the Talmudic principle (Bava Metzia 59b) that visitors should not speak until the mourner opens conversation. This practice acknowledges the mourner's emotional state and allows them to set the tone of the interaction.

[iv] This phrase from Job 2:11 regarding Job's three friends contains the dual aspects of mourning: 'lanud' (to sway/move) and 'lenaḥamo' (to comfort). The author interprets these terms mystically—the comfort process involves moving the mourner from a state dominated by divine judgment to one of consolation.

על הארץ וישוכו המים ופי׳
רוח הנחה ותנחומיו העביר
על הארץ ואז וישוכו המים
50 הזדונים. ונחמה היא מן השמי״ם
שבו נכללו הרחמים בדין ולכן
אומרים מן השמים תנוחם[i] ולנו
דרכים ישרים מאומתים בעצמם
לתת טעם לכל מה שאמרו במ״ק
55 שהאבל אסור בהם וכן עטיפתו
וישיבתו על גבי מטה כפויה
או על גבי קרקע וכן כל מה
שחייבוהו רבנן לנהוג בימי
אבלתו שאשר הוכיחו מקראי
60 שם. אך להיות כי יאריך הדרוש
בחרתי להשמיע אותם ונבון יבין
דעת מעצמו רק נציע פה לבד
ריש מלין בטעם האונן וההבראה
בהודיע כי האבל צריך סעד
65 לתומכו בתנחומים ורחמים.
פוק נא חזי כמה אתחלש חיליה
של מי שמתו מוטל לפניו כי
אפי׳ לענות אמן אחר ברכת
המברך לא הרשוהו[ii] כדאמרי׳
70 בירושלמי אם רצה להחמיר על
עצמו אין שומעין לו. וברבה פ׳
וילך אמרו כיון שרואה צרתו
לפניו דעתו מובלגת. אבל
כשנקבר כל ימי האבל הוא
75 זקוק לכל דבר של מצוה. וזה
להיותו עומד ומשפע מתוקף
הדין וכל יחוד הוא בחסד
באופן שהמקורות עליונות אינם
מתייחדות על ידו ומחוץ למחנה
80 שכינה מושבו כי היא חפצה
ביחוד ולכן האונן פטור מכל
מצות האמורות בתורה. ואמרי׳

mourner and moves him from the place of judgment's influence to a place of rest and consolation, as it is written: "God caused a wind to pass over the earth, and the waters subsided," explained as a wind of rest and consolation that passed over the earth, and then "the raging waters subsided." 50R

Comfort comes from "heaven" (shamayim), wherein mercy is included with judgment,[1] and therefore we say, "May you be comforted from Heaven." We have straightforward ways, confirmed in themselves, to provide reason for everything mentioned in Mo'ed Katan that is forbidden to the mourner, as well as his wrapping himself and sitting on an overturned bed or on the ground, and all the practices that the rabbis obligated him to observe during his days of mourning, which they derived from the verses there. However, since this inquiry would be lengthy, I have chosen to omit them, and the discerning will understand on their own. I will present here only the beginning of words on the reason for the rules of an onen [one whose dead relative is not yet buried] and the consolation meal, explaining that the mourner needs support to sustain him with comfort and mercy. 55R 60R 65R 70R

Go and see how weakened is the strength of one whose dead lies before him, for even to answer "Amen" after another's blessing was not permitted to him, as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud: "If he wishes to be stringent upon himself, we do not listen to him." And in Rabbah, parashat Vayelech, they said: "When one sees his trouble before him, his mind is confused." But when the deceased is buried, throughout the days of mourning he is obligated in all matters of commandment. 75R 80R

This is because he stands under the influence of the force of judgment,[A] and all unification is through

[A] Or: "affected by the power of divine severity" — This alternative more explicitly captures the

[1] The author engages in a wordplay with the Hebrew word 'שמים' (shamayim/heaven), which tradition interprets as a combination of 'אש' (esh/fire) representing judgment and 'מים' (mayim/water) representing mercy. This illustrates the kabbalistic concept that true comfort balances these divine attributes.

[i] This traditional phrase offered to mourners ('May you be comforted from Heaven') is explained here as having deeper significance. The word 'shamayim' (heaven) is interpreted as combining the elements of fire (esh) and water (mayim), representing the divine attributes of judgment and mercy in balance.

[ii] This refers to the halakhic status of an onen (one whose dead has not yet been buried), who is exempt from positive commandments including prayer. This exemption acknowledges the overwhelming nature of immediate grief and the mourner's need to focus on burial arrangements.

במדרש פ׳ חיי שרה על פסוק ויקם אברהם מעל פני מתו מלמד שהיה רואה מ״ה מתרים כנגדו[i] [ii]

loving-kindness, such that the supernal sources do not unify through him, and his dwelling is outside the camp of the Divine Presence, for She desires unification.[1] Therefore, the onen is exempt from all commandments stated in the Torah.[A] And it is said in the Midrash on parashat Chayei Sarah, on the verse "And Abraham rose up from before his dead," teaching that he saw the Angel of Death threatening against him.[2]

ומוכח משם שאונן פטור מכל מצות האמורות בתורה מדכתיב ויקם ואח״כ וידבר[iii] ואם ירצה האונן ליכנס למעלה בסוד עץ החיים בתפלה ותורה וברכות יערב רע שהוא בו בטוב העליון. ויכנים חול בתוך שבת ונמצא מחלל ח״ו. כי עתה ירד ללבושים תחתונים ונקרא עלה תאנה שהביאו תואנה לעולם[iv] ועל דרך זה אמרו

And it is proven from there that an onen [one whose dead relative has not yet been buried] is exempt from all the commandments stated in the Torah, as it is written "and he arose" and afterward "and he spoke." And if the onen wishes to enter above into the mystery of the Tree of Life through prayer, Torah study, and blessings, [it would be as if] he mixed evil (which is within him) with the supernal good. He would bring the mundane into the sacred, and thus be found desecrating, God forbid. For now he has descended to lower garments and is called "fig

kabbalistic understanding of 'din' as divine severity or strictness, making the mystical dimension more apparent to readers without background in Jewish mysticism.

[A] Or: "the acute mourner (onen) is exempt from all positive commandments in the Torah" — This alternative clarifies that an 'onen' is specifically an acute mourner (pre-burial) and that the exemption primarily concerns positive commandments rather than prohibitions, which provides more precise halakhic information.

[1] The original text uses the feminine form when referring to the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), which is consistently portrayed as feminine in kabbalistic literature. This reflects the kabbalistic concept of divine masculine and feminine aspects that seek unification (yichud).

[2] The Hebrew uses the abbreviation מ״ה (Mem-Heh) for מלאך המות (Malakh HaMavet/Angel of Death). This interpretation of Abraham's rising from mourning Sarah suggests that prolonged mourning can make one vulnerable to spiritual dangers.

[i] M"H (מ״ה) is an abbreviation for 'malakh ha-mavet' (מלאך המות) or Angel of Death. This midrashic interpretation of Genesis 23:3 suggests that Abraham saw the Angel of Death threatening him as he mourned Sarah, emphasizing the spiritual vulnerability of mourners.

[ii] Cf. Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah 8 — This reference establishes divine precedent for comforting mourners, showing that even God Himself performs this mitzvah. | Cf. Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer — This reference is cited to establish the significant spiritual reward associated with the mitzvah of comforting mourners. | Cf. Tractate Mo'ed Katan — The author refers to this tractate as containing the detailed halakhic framework for mourning practices, indicating that his explanations are built upon established rabbinic tradition. | Cf. Tractate Shabbat — This reference demonstrates the community's responsibility to ensure proper comfort for mourners, even organizing a minyan if needed. | Cf. Genesis 8:1 — The author interprets this verse metaphorically, comparing divine comfort after the flood to the comfort offered to mourners, suggesting both involve a transition from judgment to mercy.

[iii] This refers to Genesis 23:3, when Abraham rose up from before his dead (Sarah) and then spoke to the Hittites, implying that only after completing the mourning ritual could he engage in speech (symbolizing the Torah).

[iv] This is a wordplay on the Hebrew 'te'enah' (fig) and 'to'anah' (pretext/excuse), connecting the fig leaves of Adam and Eve (Genesis 3:7) with the spiritual state of mourning as a kind of 'pretense' that disrupts the normal spiritual order.

החכמים בטעם למה נמנע אכילת
עץ החיים לאדם הראשון אחר
שנתלבש בתנות עור ונתפשט
מכתנות אור[i] מלבד מה שדרשנו
בזה למעלה. ומטעם הנזכר
פטרו האבל מד״ת כי היא סוד
עץ החיים שבתוך הגן. ואמרי׳
במדרש רבה פ׳ צ״ח[ii] שאין
אבל נכנס בפלטרין של מלך
לכן לא נכנס יוסף בפלטרין
של פרעה במיתת אביו. וישב
בדד וידום מד״ת ותפלה בהיותו
באנינותו יען כי מטפל בכחות
הדין לצורך מתו כי האונן הוא
למטה מעלמא דדכורא ומעלמא
דנוקבא וכמעט מתאחד באינון
עבדים שהם מסטרא אחרא דאין
בהם מצות ואפי׳ עבד כנעני
שהוא בסנדלפון פטור מכמה
מצות כל שכן מרכבות שלמטה
ממנו. ומלת אונן הוא מקום
האנינות ממשלת הלילה על
כן כתיב באונן ותקרא בתי״ו
שהוא עולם הנקבה וכן פרץ
היה מצד אונן רמז שהלבנה
פרוצה. ברם אחר שקבר מתו
סליק מאתר דפגימו לעלמא
דנוקבא ונקרא אבל אבל אונן
אינו מברך כי טוב עין הוא ראוי
לברך ואינו מזמן דאין בו כח
להמשיך מעתיק ששם רמז הזימון
ואינו אוכל בשר שמשם שכר
כנזכר ואינו שותה יין פן יעורר
היין המשכר כי מאכילת דברים

leaf," which brought pretense to the world. And in this way the Sages explained why eating from the Tree of Life was prevented for Adam after he was clothed in "garments of skin" and stripped of "garments of light," beyond what we have expounded on this above. And for the reason mentioned, they exempted the mourner from words of Torah, for they are the mystery of the Tree of Life in the midst of the garden. And it says in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 98, that a mourner does not enter the palace of the king, therefore Joseph did not enter Pharaoh's palace upon his father's death. And he "sits alone and is silent" from words of Torah and prayer while in his acute mourning state, since he is engaged with the forces of judgment for the sake of his deceased, for the onen is below the masculine realm[A] and the feminine realm,[1] and almost unites with those servants who are from the Other Side, in which there are no commandments. Even a Canaanite slave, who corresponds to [the angel] Sandalfon, is exempt from several commandments, all the more so the chariots below him. And the word "onen" refers to the place of mourning, the dominion of night, therefore concerning Onan it is written "and she called" with the letter tav, which represents the feminine world, and similarly Peretz was from Onan's side, hinting that the moon is breached. However, after he has buried his dead, he ascends from the place of deficiency to the feminine realm and is called "avel" [mourner]. But an onen does not recite blessings, for though "the generous of eye is fit to bless," he does not join in the zimmun [invitation to grace after meals][2] because he lacks the power to draw down from the Ancient One, which is alluded to in the

[A] Or: "the masculine spiritual world" — Adding 'spiritual' might clarify that this isn't simply referring to a physical or gendered space, but to a kabbalistic concept representing a specific metaphysical domain.

[1] In Kabbalistic cosmology, reality is divided into various spiritual levels. The 'masculine realm' (עלמא דדכורא) represents active divine energy associated with giving, while the 'feminine realm' (עלמא דנוקבא) represents receptive divine energy. For the onen to be below both suggests an extremely low spiritual state, disconnected from normal divine influence.

[2] Zimmun is the formal invitation to recite grace after meals when three or more adult Jewish males have eaten together. The text connects this ritual to drawing down divine energy from 'the Ancient One' (עתיק), a reference to one of the highest divine configurations in Kabbalah.

[i] This refers to the rabbinic tradition that before the sin, Adam and Eve wore 'garments of light' (spiritual bodies), but after sinning, they were given 'garments of skin' (physical bodies). The Hebrew words differ only in their initial letter: אור (light) versus עור (skin).

[ii] This refers to Genesis Rabbah, chapter 98, which discusses Jacob's death and Joseph's mourning.

אלו יתלבש יותר ויותר בכחות
הגבורה ונקרא אונן מלשון בן
אוני שכמעט מדובק בכהן און
שהוא עושר[i] פי׳ בבחינה מצד
שמאל שמור לבעליו לרעתו וזהו
ויאמר אפרים אך עשרתי מצאתי
און לי פי׳ שהגביר כחו של עגלי
ירבעם ואמרי׳ בזהר שבעגל
שעשו ישראל[ii] נכלל כל כח שהיו
בשני עגלי ירבעם אחד מהם היה
בחינת הזכר של הקליפה והאחד
בחינת הנקבה הטמאה יותר.
ויירידת האונן לדיוטא התחתונה
זו הוא דוקא בחול בעוד שמתו
מוטל לפניו. ואילו יכול לישן
על גבי מטה כי ה[iii]יא מובנת
ליחוד. רק בפויה שהוא מושפע
מהאחורים לא מהפנים [iv]

zimmun. And he does not eat meat, which is from there [the spiritual source of] reward as mentioned, and he does not drink wine lest the intoxicating wine arouse [judgment], for from eating these things he would become more and more clothed in the forces of Gevurah [Strength/Judgment].[1] And he is called "onen" from the expression "ben oni" [son of my suffering], as he is almost attached to the priest of On, which refers to wealth—that is, in the aspect from the left side that is kept for its owner to his detriment. And this is [the meaning of] "And Ephraim said: I have indeed become rich, I have found wealth [on] for myself," meaning that he strengthened the power of Jeroboam's calves. And it says in the Zohar that in the calf that Israel made[2] was included all the power that was in Jeroboam's two calves—one of them was the male aspect of the kelipah [negative force], and the other was the female aspect, which is even more impure. And this descent of the onen to this lowest level occurs specifically during weekdays while his dead is laid out before him.[A] And although

[A] Or: "his deceased is still unburied" — While the literal translation is accurate, 'מוטל לפניו' is

[1] Gevurah is one of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah, representing God's strength, judgment, and discipline. In the context of mourning, excessive connection to Gevurah without the balancing force of Chesed (Loving-kindness) is considered spiritually dangerous.

[2] This refers to two different incidents of calf worship in Jewish history: the Golden Calf in the wilderness (Exodus 32) and the two calves set up by King Jeroboam I after the division of the kingdom (1 Kings 12:28-29). The text suggests a mystical connection between these two events.

[i] This refers to Potiphera, priest of On (Genesis 41:45), whose name is interpreted as relating to wealth (און can be read as 'on', a city, or as 'wealth'). The text creates a connection between this priest and the spiritual state of an onen.

[ii] This references Zoharic teaching that the Golden Calf made in the wilderness (Exodus 32) contained the same negative spiritual forces later embodied in Jeroboam's two calves (1 Kings 12:28-29), which split the kingdom of Israel.

[iii] The overturned bed is a traditional sign of mourning in Jewish practice, symbolizing the disruption of normal life and the reversal of joy.

[iv] Cf. Sefer Ha-Zohar — The text references Zoharic teaching about how the Golden Calf contained the spiritual powers later manifested in Jeroboam's two calves. This connects the sin of idolatry with the spiritual state of an onen, suggesting that both represent an improper mixing of realms. | Cf. Genesis 3:7 — The reference to 'fig leaf' (עלה תאנה) alludes to Adam and Eve's first coverings after their sin, creating a parallel between their spiritual descent and the state of an onen who has temporarily descended to a lower spiritual level. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, earlier section — The author refers to an earlier explanation ('מלבד מה שדרשנו בזה למעלה') about Adam's transformation from wearing 'garments of light' to 'garments of skin', which serves as a metaphor for the onen's temporary spiritual descent. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah Genesis 98 — This reference to Joseph's behavior during mourning for Jacob serves as a biblical precedent for the halakhic concept that mourners should not enter places of honor or authority. | Cf. Genesis 35:18 — The text draws a connection between the term 'onen' and 'ben oni' (son of my suffering) from Rachel's naming of Benjamin, suggesting that the mourner's state is one of suffering and connection to death. | Cf. Genesis 38:1-10 — The text makes a wordplay between the halakhic term 'onen' and the biblical character Onan, suggesting that both represent a form of spiritual deficiency related to improper sexual/spiritual energy.

he could sleep on a bed, for it is prepared for unification, [it must be] overturned, for he is influenced by the "back" aspects, not the "face" aspects.[1] 160R

150 אבל בשבת ויום טוב כח ההנהגה
הקדושה המתגלית ביום ההוא
תגין עליו לבל ירד פלאים: ולכן
אין לעסוק בצרכי מתו בשבת
ואפי׳ ביום טוב ראשון הוא על
155 ידי עממים וחייב בכל מצות
האמורות בתורה אך בתשמיש
המטה שהוא בחינת היחוד
בעצמו יש אומרים שאינו כדאי
לכך ואסרוהו לו ואחר שהעלה
160 מתו למקום מנוחתו כובע ישועה
על ראשו וחייב בכל המצות
אך אינו ראוי לאכילת קדשים
שהוא לעורר בחותיהם עליו
וליהנות מזיום ביחוד הפנימי
165 של אברים פנימיים בחדרי בטן
ורזי עולם ותעלומות סתרי
כל חי סוד הנשמה המחיה הכל
אין כח להראות בעצמו כך
עד יעבור עליו יום המר שהוא
170 יום ראשון ממיתה וקבורה
ופי׳ הסבא בפ׳ משפטים דף
ק״א ע״ב דקדש הוא מעלמא
דדכורא שהוא מיסוד ולמעלה
קדוש הוא ומסתלק לעיל והאבל
175 ביום ראשון משבעת ימי אבלו
הוא בעלמא דנוקבא ובגין
דלית ליה מגרמיה כלום אוכל
מלחם הנשפע לו מאחרים ואם
עבר יום ראשון ולא אכל כגון
180 שמתענה כיון דאידחת ההבראה
אידחת שנתעלה לסוד עלמא
דדכורא: וזה יהיה גם כן טעם
שפטור מהנחת תפלין[i] כי איך

But on the Sabbath and festivals, the power of the sacred governance that is revealed on that day protects him so that he does not descend to the depths. Therefore, one should not attend to the needs of one's deceased on the Sabbath, and even on the first 165R
day of a festival this is done through gentiles. He is obligated in all the commandments stated in the Torah, except for marital relations, which is itself an aspect of unification. Some say he is not worthy of this and have forbidden it to him. 170R

After he has brought his deceased to his resting place, a crown of salvation is upon his head,[2] and he is obligated in all the commandments. However, he is not fit to eat sacred foods, which would awaken their powers upon him and to enjoy their radiance 175R
in the internal unification of the inner organs in the chambers of the belly, and the mysteries of the world, and the concealed secrets of all living things—the secret of the soul that vivifies everything. He lacks the power to manifest this within himself until the 180R
bitter day has passed, which is the first day after death and burial.

The Elder (Sabba) explains in Parashat Mishpatim, page 101b, that "holy" (kodesh) belongs to the masculine realm, which is from Yesod and above. It 185R
is sacred and ascends upward, while the mourner on the first of his seven days of mourning is in the feminine realm. And because he has nothing of his own, he eats from the bread that flows to him from others. If the first day has passed and he has not eaten, 190R
such as if he is fasting, since the consolation meal has been set aside, it is set aside, and he is elevated to the secret of the masculine realm.

This will also be the reason why he is exempt

a technical halakhic term referring to the status of a deceased who has not yet been buried. A slightly more explanatory translation might be clearer to readers unfamiliar with the concept.

[1] In Kabbalah, 'face' (פנים) represents direct divine influence and connection, while 'back' (אחוריים) represents indirect, diminished divine influence. The mourner's state is characterized by this reduction in direct divine connection, symbolized by sleeping on an overturned bed.

[2] The Hebrew phrase 'כובע ישועה על ראשו' (literally 'helmet of salvation on his head') is a metaphorical expression indicating that after burial, the mourner's spiritual status is elevated from the depths of mourning.

[i] The text is discussing the exemption of a mourner from wearing tefillin (phylacteries) on the first day of mourning, explaining it through kabbalistic concepts of the 'masculine' and 'feminine' realms.

יתפאר בכחות הרחמים בעלמא
185 דדכורא ועדיין הוא מלובש בדין
בעלמא דנוקבא[i] שלכן אשה
שרוצה להניח תפלין מוחין בידה
מה שאין כן בשאר מצות עשה
שפטורה מהם ומיכל בת שאול
190 שאני דבת מלך היתה.[ii] ועוד
שהיתה תוכה כברה ורמז לזה
נתנו דורשי רשומות כי מיכל
בא״ת ב״ש הוא מיכל.[iii] ועדיפת
מינה שהיתה אשת דוד. ועוד יש
195 אומרים שמנעו אותה. והמבין
סוד שער של תפלין יבין עוד
טעם לשבח למה האבל פטור
מהם ביום ראשון וכן בט״ב
שבעונותינו ירדנו פלאים
200 אין מניחין תפלין בבקר בעת
האבל. וראיתי יחידים שאינם
מונעים עצמם מתפלין לא ביום
א׳ של אבלות וגם לא בט״ב
ועיין בדברי הפוסקים בזה.
205 והמניחים ב׳ זוג תפלין מניח
ביום ט״ב תפלין של רש״י
לבד שכחן יפה להיות כסדר
כתיבתן בתורה וקבלום עליהם
רוב העולם ונמצאו על בימת
210 יחזקאל הנביא אמנם בשאר
הימים שניהם יחד טובים כפי
ההנהגות בנודע מגלוי שמר
ת״ם וראה יש״ר שהוא רש״י

from putting on tefillin, for how can he glory in 195R
the powers of mercy in the masculine realm while
he is still clothed in judgment in the feminine
realm?[1] This is why a woman who wants to put
on tefillin is prevented from doing so, unlike other
positive commandments from which she is exempt. 200R
Michal the daughter of Saul was different because
she was a king's daughter. Furthermore, her inside
was like her outside, and as a hint to this, the
interpreters of symbols noted that "Michal" in
Atbash is "Mich[2]al." Moreover, she was the wife of 205R
David. Some also say that they prevented her from
doing so.

One who understands the secret of the hair of
tefillin will understand yet another reason to explain
why the mourner is exempt from them on the first 210R
day. Similarly, on the Ninth of Av, when because of
our sins we have descended to the depths,[3] tefillin are
not worn in the morning during the time of mourn-
ing. I have seen individuals who do not refrain from
tefillin, neither on the first day of mourning nor on 215R
the Ninth of Av. See the words of the legal authori-
ties on this.

Those who wear two pairs of tefillin should wear
only Rashi's tefillin on the Ninth of Av, as their
power is appropriate to follow the order of their writ- 220R
ing in the Torah. Most of the world has accepted
them, and they were found on the platform of Ezekiel
the prophet. However, on other days, both together
are good according to the various modes of gover-

[1]This passage explains mourning practices through kabbalistic concepts of masculine (mercy) and feminine (judgment) divine attributes. The mourner exists in a state dominated by judgment (the feminine realm) rather than mercy (the masculine realm), which affects which commandments they can properly fulfill.

[2]This kabbalistic wordplay notes that Michal's name remains unchanged when encoded with the Atbash substitution cipher, where each Hebrew letter is replaced with its counterpart from the opposite end of the alphabet. This unchanging quality is interpreted as symbolizing her spiritual integrity.

[3]The Hebrew phrase 'ירדנו פלאים' (we have descended to the depths) is an allusion to Lamentations 1:9, connecting the personal mourning of an individual with the national mourning for the destruction of the Temple commemorated on the Ninth of Av.

[i]This refers to the kabbalistic concept where the 'feminine realm' (עלמא דנוקבא) is associated with judgment and restriction, while the 'masculine realm' (עלמא דדכורא) is associated with mercy and expansion.

[ii]Refers to the Talmudic tradition that Michal, daughter of King Saul and wife of King David, wore tefillin despite women generally being exempt from this commandment.

[iii]This refers to the Atbash cipher, a Hebrew substitution code where each letter is replaced with the letter symmetrically opposite it in the alphabet. The author is pointing out that Michal's name remains unchanged when encoded with Atbash, suggesting her inner and outer nature were aligned.

[iv]This refers to the two traditions of tefillin arrangement: Rashi's method and Rabbenu Tam's

ור״ת[i] וזה צריך שמוש חכמים.
וכל אלו רמזים מלבד פשוטן של
דברים הכתובים בדברי הגמרא
והפוסקים שהם אמת ותורתן
אמת ומנייהו לא נזוע ובזה
פתחנו קצת פתח לכל הדברים
האסורים לאבל והחכם יבין דעת
ויוסיף משלו כי מה ידעתי אני
הקטן אפרוח שלא נפתחו עיניו
ולא ידע כל תלמידהון דרבנן
וגם אויל מחריש חכם יחשב:[iii] [ii]

nance, as is known from the revelation that Tam observed, and Yashar saw, which is Rashi and Rabbenu Tam,[1] and this requires the instruction of sages. 225R

All these are hints beyond the plain meaning of the matters written in the words of the Talmud and legal authorities, which are true and whose Torah is true, and from them we shall not move. With this, we have opened a small doorway to all the things forbidden to a mourner, and the wise will understand knowledge and add from their own, for what do I know, I, the small one, a chick whose eyes have not yet opened and who does not know all the disciples of the rabbis? Even a silent fool may be considered wise.[2] 230R 235R

פרק ל״ה

Chapter 35

כתוב בר״מ פ׳ עקב[iv] אוקמוה
רבנן דמתני׳ שעת אכילה
שעת מלחמה.[v] וזה לפי
שהמלפתים ארחותם נגד בני
אדם[vi] להדיחם מעל ה׳ מזדמנים

It is written in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Ekev, that our Rabbis of the Mishnah established that "the time of eating is the time of battle."[3] This is because those who twist their paths against mankind to lead them away from God[A] gather 5R

[A] Or: "This is because the demonic forces who corrupt their ways against humans to seduce them

[1] These refer to two different traditions for arranging the scriptural passages within tefillin (phylacteries). Some pious individuals wear both types, first Rashi's arrangement (the more common practice) and then Rabbenu Tam's arrangement.

[2] The author concludes with a self-deprecating reference to Proverbs 17:28, suggesting that his own silence on deeper matters might be wiser than attempting explanations beyond his capability.

[3] This rabbinic saying views mealtime as a spiritual battlefield where negative forces attempt to influence humans, explaining why ritual precautions are necessary during meals.

method. Some pious individuals wear both types, particularly those following kabbalistic practices.

[i] A reference to Proverbs 17:28: 'Even a fool who keeps silent is considered wise.'

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Mishpatim — The text directly quotes the Zohar's explanation about the spiritual status of mourners, specifically how they exist in the 'feminine realm' (associated with judgment) rather than the 'masculine realm' (associated with mercy). This Zoharic passage forms the theological foundation for the mourning practices discussed. | Cf. Talmud, Eruvin — The text references the Talmudic discussion about Michal daughter of Saul wearing tefillin, which was unusual since women are generally exempt from this time-bound commandment. This reference serves to illustrate exceptions to the general rules about who may appropriately wear tefillin. | Cf. Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim — While not directly cited, the text alludes to the halakhic discussions about mourners being exempt from tefillin on the first day, which is codified in the Shulchan Aruch. The author is providing mystical reasons for a practice established in halakhic literature. | Cf. Lamentations — The phrase 'ירדנו פלאים' (we have descended to the depths) echoes language from Lamentations, connecting personal mourning with national mourning for the destruction of the Temple, particularly relevant to the discussion of the Ninth of Av. | Cf. Proverbs — The author concludes with a direct reference to this verse ('Even a fool who keeps silent is considered wise') as a self-deprecating way to suggest that his own limitations in explaining deeper mystical concepts might make silence the wiser course.

[iii] Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd), a section of the Zohar, on the Torah portion of Ekev.

[iv] A rabbinic saying that mealtime is a time of spiritual battle against negative forces.

[v] Refers to demonic or negative spiritual forces that attempt to lead humans astray.

שם בראותם שהחומר נהנה מהעה״ז. לכן אמרו שהם בכלבים עזי נפש[i] שאינם נדחים משם בדחייה ראשונה. על כן צריך שתי הזמנות לברכה מלבד חלקם הניתן להם במים אחרונים של מקום חובה[ii] יורדים פן יערבבו שמחת הברכה שעולה ביחודה על כל שאר ברכות הנהנין על כן היא מן התורה. וכ״ש שיסולו דרכם יחד בסעודת האבל. לכן המנחמים היו מברכים ברכת רחבה[iii] להשפיע עליו ועליהם משפע רחובות הנהר[iv] המריק ברכות עד בלי די כנזכר לעיל. ולכן האבל יושב בראש[v] כדאיתא פרק אלו מגלחין[vi] מקום מוצא ההשפעה כי הוא צריך לחסד אל בעצם ובראשונה להיות החרב שלופה לקראתו ונוטל ידיו תחלה ואח״כ המנחמים. ונמצא כתוב במנהגים שהוא בוצע המוציא על הפרוסה שנותנים לפניו ומברך לעצמו ואח״כ בוצעין המנחמים לעצמן וכן מוזגין הכוס ונותנים לפניו

there, seeing that the physical body derives pleasure from this world. Therefore, they said that these [negative forces] are like brazen dogs that are not repelled by a first rejection. Thus, two invitations to blessing are required,[1] besides their portion given to them in the mayim achronim (final hand-washing) which is obligatory, lest they disturb the joy of the blessing[A] which, in its unification, rises above all other blessings over enjoyment, and is therefore ordained by the Torah. All the more so do they clear a path together at the mourner's meal. Therefore, the comforters would recite the "Blessing of Expansiveness"[B] to channel influence upon him and themselves from the abundance of "the expanses of the river" which pours forth blessings without limit, as mentioned above. This is why the mourner sits at the head[2] [of the table], as stated in chapter Elu Megalchin, at the source of divine influence, for he primarily and essentially needs God's loving-kindness, as the sword is drawn toward him.[3] He washes his hands first, and then the comforters [wash theirs].

It is written in the customs that the mourner breaks bread over the piece placed before him and says the blessing for himself, after which the comforters break bread for themselves. Similarly, they

away from God" — The term 'המלפתים' could refer more specifically to demonic entities rather than general negative forces. This translation makes the supernatural element more explicit, which may better reflect the author's cosmology.

[A] Or: "lest they confuse and disrupt the joy of the blessing" — The Hebrew 'יערבבו' has connotations of mixing/confusing beyond mere disturbance, suggesting these forces create spiritual confusion that undermines the blessing's efficacy.

[B] Or: "the Rechavah blessing" — This may be referring to a specific named blessing rather than a descriptive category. Maintaining the Hebrew term with transliteration might be more precise if this is a formal title of a blessing.

[1] This refers to the custom of saying 'Rabotai nevarech' (Gentlemen, let us bless) before the Grace After Meals, which is considered an invitation that helps ward off negative spiritual forces.

[2] This reverses the normal social hierarchy, placing the mourner in the position of highest honor as a form of comfort and recognition of their need for spiritual support.

[3] A metaphorical expression indicating that the mourner is under the threat of divine judgment and therefore particularly needs divine mercy and protection.

[i] Comparing negative spiritual forces to brazen dogs, a metaphor for their persistence.

[ii] Refers to the ritual hand-washing after meals (mayim achronim), which was considered obligatory and traditionally understood as giving a portion to the 'forces of impurity'.

[iii] A special blessing of consolation recited for mourners, associated with expansiveness and divine abundance.

[iv] A kabbalistic reference to divine abundance flowing from the 'expanses of the river,' a celestial source of blessing.

[v] The custom that the mourner sits at the head of the table, unlike regular meals where the host or most distinguished guest would sit there.

[vi] Chapter 'These May Shave' in Tractate Mo'ed Katan, which deals with laws of mourning.

ומברך לעצמו ושותה ואח״כ הם מברכין לעצמן ושותים. הנה כי כוונת אכילתו ושתייתו משונה מכוונת אכילת המנחמים לזה הוא מברך לעצמו תחלה והם לעצמם ואסמכוה אקרא דכתיב אבחר דרכם ואשב ראש כאשר אבלים ינחם. ואמרו ג״כ כי מנהג שאין שותין בכוסו אלא לאחר שמדיחין אותו והבוצע בסעודת האבל שהוא דוגמא דעמודא דאמצעיתא[i] דהיא חייתא עילאה קדישא[ii] דכל שאר חיותא אחידן ביה ואשתלשלו בגוה כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ בשלח דף מ״ז ע״ב לכן הבוצע נותן פרוסה ביד האבל וזו הוא הכנה לו לנחמו מכל אחד מז׳ הבלים[iii] כי הוא מתפאר ומתאחד בתוכן כנודע. וכיון שזכה ללחם מן הארץ שהיא בתר הנקרא זאת[iv] מיוחדת עם ת״ת בזאת יבא ליכנס אל הקדש.[v] והביצה היא רמז למלכות בסוד אור החוזר כדפי׳ בתקונים הנה לחם וביצה סוד אור ישר וחוזר[vi] ע״כ הביצה היא

pour a cup and place it before him; he says the blessing for himself and drinks, and then they say the blessing for themselves and drink. Thus, the intention behind his eating and drinking differs from the intention behind the comforters' eating, which is why he blesses for himself first and they bless for themselves. They based this on the verse: "I would choose their way and sit as chief, as a king among his troops, as one who comforts mourners." 35R 40R

They also said that the custom is not to drink from his cup until it has been rinsed,[1] and that the one who breaks bread at the mourner's meal, representing the central column[A] which is the holy supernal life-force to which all other living beings are connected and from which they are extended, as stated in Parashat Beshalach, page 47b, therefore gives a piece of bread to the mourner. This prepares him to be comforted through each of the seven "breaths," for he is glorified and unified within them, as is known. Since he has merited bread from the earth,[2] which is the crown called "Zot" (This)[B] that is united with Tiferet through "bezot" (with this) to enter the holy, and the egg symbolizes Malkhut[3] in the mystery of reflected light, as explained in Tikkunim—thus bread and egg represent the mystery of direct and reflected 45R 50R 55R

[A] Or: "who is the embodiment of the central pillar" — The term 'דוגמא' suggests embodiment or manifestation rather than mere representation, indicating a stronger ontological connection between the person breaking bread and the divine attribute of Tiferet.

[B] Or: "the sefirah of Keter which is called 'Zot'" — While the translation accurately captures the meaning, this alternate more explicitly identifies 'crown' as referring to the specific sefirah of Keter in kabbalistic terminology, which might be clearer for readers less familiar with kabbalistic language.

[1] This custom reflects concerns about spiritual contamination associated with mourning, requiring purification of vessels before others use them.

[2] The author interprets bread mystically, connecting it to divine attributes and the process of spiritual elevation during the mourner's meal.

[3] The egg served at the mourner's meal is interpreted as representing Malkhut (the lowest sefirah), connected to the concept of reflected light returning upward to its divine source.

[i] In Kabbalah, this refers to Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), the central column of the sefirotic tree that balances mercy and judgment.

[ii] The holy supernal life-force, referring to the divine vitality that flows through the central column of the sefirot.

[iii] The 'seven breaths' or emanations mentioned in Ecclesiastes and interpreted in Kabbalah as divine creative forces that sustain existence.

[iv] The crown (a divine attribute) called 'Zot' (This), referring to the Shekhinah or divine presence.

[v] Allusion to Leviticus 16:3, 'With this (bezot) shall Aaron enter the sanctuary,' interpreted mystically.

[vi] The kabbalistic concept of 'direct light' (divine energy flowing downward) and 'reflected light' (energy returning upward), central to Lurianic Kabbalah.

מגולגלת ומשם עולה למדרגה יין המשמח[i] שהוא פרי מן העץ החיים.[ii] וכיון שהוציא וזכה להשפעה לחם ויין משם להיות כהן לאל עליון חסד אל[iii] ולכן נברא יין לשמח אבלים. ולהיות המנחמים עסוקים לעורר ג״ח העליונים לכן הרואים פני האבל [iv]

light—therefore the egg is round. From there, he ascends to the level of wine that gladdens, which is fruit from the Tree of Life. And since he has brought forth and merited the influence of bread and wine from there, to be a priest to God Most High, the God of loving-kindness, therefore wine was created to gladden mourners.[1] And since the comforters are engaged in arousing the celestial acts of loving-kindness, those who see the face of the mourner

פטורים מן התפלה כי תקונם במקום גבוה יותר מהתעוררות התפלה. ואמרי׳ בויקרא רבה פ׳ ל״ד על פסוק ועניים מרודים תביא בית אלו אבלים ומרי נפש. ומי משמחן יין. הנה כי שפע יין המשומר והמשמח מביא בבית ומכנים להכלל בעלמא דדכורא

Those who are present with mourners are exempt from prayer because their spiritual work is taking place at a higher level than the awakening of prayer.[A][2] And it is said in Leviticus Rabbah chapter 34, on the verse "bring the poor who are cast out to your house" (Isaiah 58:7)—these refer to mourners and those of bitter spirit. And what comforts them? Wine.[B] Thus we see that the flow

[A] Or: "because their rectification occurs in a place higher than the arousal of prayer" — The term 'תקונם' (tikkunam) has kabbalistic connotations of rectification or repair of the cosmic order, which might be more precisely captured with this alternate translation.

[B] Or: "And what gladdens them? Wine" — The root ש-מ-ח specifically refers to gladness or joy rather than comfort, which would more precisely capture the midrashic interpretation.

[1] A striking theological claim that wine's purpose includes comforting mourners, giving religious significance to the custom of serving wine at consolation meals.

[2] The text establishes a hierarchical relationship between different forms of religious service, with comforting mourners ranked as spiritually superior to regular prayer. This reflects a common rabbinic prioritization of interpersonal mitzvot (commandments between humans) over ritual mitzvot (commandments between humans and God).

[i] Wine that gladdens, referencing Psalm 104:15, with mystical significance of wine as representing divine secrets and spiritual joy.

[ii] Fruit from the Tree of Life, a mystical reference connecting wine to the primordial Tree of Life in Eden.

[iii] Priest to God Most High, the God of loving-kindness, connecting the mourner's spiritual role to the biblical Melchizedek (Genesis 14:18).

[iv] Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The text explicitly references the 'Tikkunim' when explaining the mystical significance of the egg at the mourner's meal, showing how ritual foods are interpreted through kabbalistic concepts of divine light patterns. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — The text directly cites this section of the Zohar regarding the central column (Tiferet) as the source of vitality for all living beings, using it to explain the mystical significance of bread distribution at the mourner's meal. | Cf. Tractate Mo'ed Katan — The text refers to this Talmudic source for the custom of the mourner sitting at the head of the table, showing how the author grounds mystical interpretations in established halakhic texts. | Cf. Ecclesiastes — The mention of 'seven breaths' (shivah havalim) alludes to Ecclesiastes, which kabbalistic tradition interprets as divine creative forces that sustain existence, connected here to comforting the mourner. | Cf. Leviticus 16:3 — The phrase 'bezot yavo liknos el hakodesh' echoes the biblical instruction to Aaron, mystically connecting the mourner's spiritual state to the High Priest's ritual purity requirements. | Cf. Genesis 14:18 — The reference to being 'a priest to God Most High' echoes the description of Melchizedek, suggesting the mourner temporarily assumes a priestly spiritual function in the context of the ritual meal. | Cf. Book of Job 29:25 — The text explicitly cites this verse as the scriptural basis for the mourner sitting at the head of the table, showing how ritual practices are derived from biblical precedents.

האבל ומר נפש. וזה טעם ג״כ
שהעוסקים בצרכי רבים פטורים
מן התפלה[i] וכן בצרכי חתן
וכלה כנראה בפ׳ בלק בעובדא
דההוא ינוקא.[ii] וממה שכתוב
ר״מ פ׳ עקב דף רע״א ע״ב בסדר
הסבת הסעודה למארי סעודתא
דמלכא הוא כי גדול מסב בראש
תניינא תחותיה ותליתאה תחות
תניינא ואמר דאלין אתקריאו
ג׳ מטות לקבל ג׳ אבהן לקבל
כהנים לוים וישראלים[iii] ומכאן
ואילך לית להו סדר אלא כל
הקודם זכה. נ״ל ג״כ שהסדר
הזה הוא במנחמי האבל שאחר
הג׳ מנחמים הראשונים איש
כפי מדרגתו כל הקודם זכה
משם ואילך וכן יהיה ברחיצת
ידי האבל בסוד אם רחץ ה׳
את צואת בנות ציון שכל א׳
מתכוין לעשות ג״ח זה לו והכל
הוא להבריח מעל ידיו כחות
ששורות בו כי האצבעות הם
התפשטות הכחות עד למרחק עד
אחיזתם סמוך לחצונים[iv] לכן
קרובה הקליפה להתאחז שם

of the preserved and gladdening wine brings into the house and enables the mourner and the bitter of spirit to be included in the masculine realm.[A1] This is also the reason why those engaged in communal needs are exempt from prayer, as well as those 80R attending to the needs of a bride and groom, as appears in Parashat Balak in the story of that child. And from what is written in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Ekev, page 271b, regarding the order of reclining at a feast for the master of the king's feast: 85R the greatest reclines at the head, the second beneath him, and the third beneath the second. And it states that these are called the "three couches," corresponding to the three Patriarchs and to the priests, Levites, and Israelites. Beyond these, there 90R is no set order—rather, whoever comes first merits the position.

It seems to me that this order also applies to those who comfort mourners—after the first three comforters, each according to his rank, whoever comes 95R first merits the position thereafter.[2] And so it should be with the washing of the mourner's hands, in the mystical sense of "when the Lord has washed away the filth of the daughters of Zion" (Isaiah 4:4), as each person intends to perform this act of kindness 100R for him. The whole purpose is to drive away from

[A] Or: "to be incorporated into the masculine world" — The kabbalistic term 'עלמא דדכורא' refers to the masculine cosmic dimension in Lurianic Kabbalah, which could be translated as 'world' rather than 'realm' to maintain the cosmic dimension implied.

[1] The Hebrew 'עלמא דדכורא' (alma de-dikhura) is a kabbalistic term referring to the masculine aspect of divinity, associated with mercy and giving. The text suggests that wine helps elevate mourners from the 'feminine realm' (associated with judgment and receptivity) to the 'masculine realm' (associated with mercy and giving), which represents spiritual elevation and comfort.

[2] The text establishes a system where the first three positions follow a strict hierarchical order, but positions beyond these are assigned on a first-come basis. This principle is then applied both to seating arrangements at meals and to the order of comforting mourners.

[i] This refers to the halakhic principle that those engaged in one mitzvah are exempt from another mitzvah. Here it specifically indicates that those who are comforting mourners, attending to communal needs, or attending to wedding preparations are exempt from regular prayer obligations because they are already engaged in an important mitzvah.

[ii] This refers to a story in the Zohar where a child (yanuka) offers mystical interpretations. The text is referencing a specific narrative in the Zohar on Parashat Balak where exemption from regular prayer obligations is discussed.

[iii] This establishes a correspondence between the three highest positions at a meal with both the three Patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob) and the three divisions of the Jewish people (Kohanim, Leviim, and Israelites). Such correspondences between mundane practices and cosmic structures are typical of kabbalistic thinking.

[iv] This presents the kabbalistic view that fingers are physical extensions of spiritual forces that reach outward toward the boundary with negative spiritual forces (chitzonim). This explains why hands and fingers are particularly vulnerable to spiritual impurity and require ritual washing.

וכו׳ ובישמעאל ידו בכל ויד
כל בו[i] והצפרנים הם הקליפות
שהם מותרי הכבוד[ii] ולכן צואה
שתחת הצפורן חוצץ בטבילה
שנראה טובל ושרץ בידו. ומה גם
שלא כנגד הבשר שאז הטומאה
היא במקום המותרות מכל וכל:
ולפי שכשאדם ישן ביציאת
נשמתו רוח טומאה שורה על
גופו[iii] ומטמאו כמו שבמותו רוח
רעה וטומאה שורה עליו אך
בחזרת נשמתו לו מתעברת ההיא
זוהמא מגופו ונשארת בידים
לבד והם עדיין מתות במיתה
וטומאה. על כן אין לברך בידים
מסואבות מפני שהטומאה נוטלת
חלקה מהברכה ח״ו והנשמה
מתפשטת בתוך המיתה. ובזה
יצא לנו טעם לשבח רחיצת ידי
האבל שכל הטומאה והרוחות
נאספו בידיו. לכן מנהג לשפוך
כל המים שבכלי אחר שנטל
ידו מהם[iv] כדאמרי׳ במים של
שחרית. ובכח מי חסד שיריקו
עלידיו יתפרדו כל פועלי און
ומה טוב להריק עליו המים בג׳
פעמים דלא גרע מנט״י שחרית
דבת מלך היא ומקפדת עד ג׳
פעמים. ואינה רוח בעלמא כמו
ידים המטונפות מבית הכסא.
ולכן שופכים אותם המים במקום
מדרון החוצה לרוחות הפורחות
כי בזה בעלי החובה יקחו חלקם

his hands the forces that dwell within them, for the fingers are the extension of spiritual powers reaching outward to the point where they can almost grasp the external forces. Therefore, the negative shell (kelipah) is close to attaching itself there, etc. Regarding Ishmael, it is written "his hand will be against everyone, and everyone's hand against him" (Genesis 16:12). The fingernails are the shells (kelipot) which are the excess of honor, and therefore excrement under the fingernail creates a barrier during ritual immersion, as it appears that one is immersing while holding an unclean creature.[1] This is especially true when it is not against the flesh, for then the impurity is entirely in the place of excess.

Because when a person sleeps and his soul departs, a spirit of impurity rests upon his body and defiles it, just as at death an evil spirit and impurity rest upon him. But when his soul returns to him, that contamination passes from his body and remains only in the hands, which are still "dead" with death and impurity. Therefore, one should not recite blessings with defiled hands, because the impurity takes its portion from the blessing, God forbid, and the soul spreads within death. This explains the commendable practice of washing the mourner's hands, for all the impurity and spirits gather in his hands. Therefore, the custom is to pour out all the water in the vessel after he has washed his hands with it, as we say regarding the morning hand-washing. Through the power of the waters of kindness poured over his hands, all workers of iniquity will be scattered.[2] And it is good to pour the water over him three times, for this is

[1] This connects a practical halakhic ruling (that dirt under fingernails invalidates ritual immersion) with a kabbalistic interpretation involving the concept of kelipot (negative spiritual forces). The text views the physical world as reflecting and embodying spiritual realities.

[2] The text uses the phrase 'waters of kindness' (mei chesed) to describe the water used in hand-washing, suggesting that the physical act has metaphysical effects in dispersing negative spiritual forces. This reflects the kabbalistic view that physical rituals affect spiritual realms.

[i] The text cites Genesis 16:12 about Ishmael, whose name contains the Hebrew word for hand (yad), as a prooftext for the concept that hands can be problematic from a spiritual perspective.

[ii] The fingernails are described as 'shells' or 'husks' (kelipot), which in Kabbalah refers to external coverings that can harbor negative spiritual forces. They are called 'excess of honor' (moterei ha-kavod) because they represent the outermost extension of the human form.

[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that during sleep, the higher aspects of the soul temporarily leave the body, allowing a 'spirit of impurity' to rest upon it. This is why hand-washing upon awakening (netilat yadayim) is required before prayer or Torah study.

[iv] This describes the custom of discarding water used for washing a mourner's hands, based on the concept that the water absorbs spiritual impurity. A similar practice is observed with the water used for the morning hand-washing ritual.

ויתרחקו מעל האבל. ואין לערב
135 מים במים פן יחזקו מוסרותם
כי פיזור לרשעים הנאה לעולם
ובזה יבושו ויחתו מגבורתם.
ועוד הג׳ פעמים ירמזו לג׳
הנהגות שיחדו יהיו תמים להריק
140 עליו שפע שבע רצון ע״כ מנהג
לעשות חסד זה ע״י גדולים
המנחמים. וגם בזה נאמר כי
מהג׳ ראשונים ואילך אין להם
סדר כי כשנעמיק בדברי ר״מ
145 בטעם שנתן לדבריו. סדר זה
יהיה בנין אב בכל מקום שיש
רבים ונכבדים וגם שבנטילת
ידים שבסוף הסעודה פסק
מהרר״י קארו בסי׳ קפ״א שכיון
150 שלא נשארו אלא ה׳ מהמסובין
שלא נטלו ידיהם באחרונה אז
נוטל המברך ולא שמר שם הסדר
מר״מ מהג׳ כבר כתבו הטעם
שהוא מפני עיון הד׳ ברכות
155 של ברהמ״ז כמתבאר שם: ברם
בעליית ס״ת יש סדר אפי׳ אחר
כהן לוי ישראל מפני שהס״ת הוא
דיוקנא דזעיר והוא במקום הג׳
מטות ששם יש סדר. לכן אמרו
160 אחריהם מי קורא וכו׳ בדאיתא
במס׳ מגילה. ושם בר״מ פי׳ כי
ידים מזוהמות [i]

no less important than the morning hand-washing, 135R
which is like a king's daughter who insists on three
pourings. This is not merely a mundane spirit, like
hands soiled from the bathroom. Therefore, the
water is poured out in a downward-sloping place
outside, toward the flying spirits, for in this way the 140R
liable entities will take their portion and distance
themselves from the mourner. One should not mix
water with water, lest their bonds be strengthened,
for the scattering of the wicked benefits the world,
and by this they will be ashamed and dismayed 145R
from their strength.[1] Furthermore, the three
pourings allude to three forms of divine governance
which together will be perfect in pouring upon him
an abundance of satisfied will.[2] Therefore, it is
the custom to perform this kindness through the 150R
prominent comforters.

And in this matter too, we say that from the first
three onward, there is no set order, for when we delve
deeply into the words of Ra'aya Mehemna and the
reason he gave for his words, this order will serve as 155R
a fundamental principle in every place where there
are many distinguished people. Also, regarding the
hand-washing at the end of the meal, Rabbi Joseph
Karo ruled in section 181 that when only five of those
reclining remain who have not washed their hands 160R
at the end, then the one who will recite the bless-
ing washes, without keeping the order from Ra'aya
Mehemna from the three. The reason has already
been explained—it is due to the contemplation of

[1] This instruction not to mix waters from different hand-washings reflects a concern that the impurity absorbed by the water might be strengthened rather than dissipated if waters are combined. The phrase 'scattering of the wicked benefits the world' (pizur laresha'im hana'ah la'olam) is a rabbinic principle applied here to spiritual forces.

[2] The threefold pouring of water is given cosmic significance, corresponding to the three primary modes of divine governance in kabbalistic thought: chesed (loving-kindness), din (judgment), and rachamim (mercy). Together, these create a balanced flow of divine blessing.

[i] Cf. Isaiah 58:7 — The author uses this biblical verse as interpreted in Leviticus Rabbah to establish that mourners require special care and hospitality, which explains why attending to them takes precedence over regular prayer obligations. | Cf. Leviticus Rabbah Chapter 34 — The author cites this midrash to establish that wine has special significance for comforting mourners, which is then given a kabbalistic interpretation about elevating mourners from the feminine to the masculine cosmic realm. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna on Parashat Ekev — The author uses this kabbalistic text to establish ritual precedent for the order of comforting mourners, suggesting that mystical principles from meal protocols apply to mourning practices as well. | Cf. Isaiah 4:4 — The author interprets hand-washing for mourners as a physical ritual with cosmic significance, drawing a parallel between the purification of Jerusalem described in Isaiah and the purification of the mourner through the hand-washing ritual. | Cf. Genesis 16:12 — The author uses this biblical verse to illustrate the concept that hands can be spiritually problematic, connecting Ishmael's adversarial nature with the kabbalistic concept that hands can be vulnerable to negative spiritual forces.

the four blessings of Grace After Meals, as explained there. However, for the Torah reading, there is an order even after the Cohen, Levi, and Israelite, because the Torah scroll is the image of Zeir Anpin[A] and stands in place of the three couches where there is order.[1] Therefore, they said after them "who reads," etc., as appears in Tractate Megillah. And there in Ra'aya Mehemna it explains that defiled hands

פסולות לברכה דאינון שניות לטומא׳.[i] וכד אינון טהורו׳ אינון שניות לברכה[ii] דברכה לא שריא אלא על טהרה והכהן שהוא איש טהור איש חסד. שריא עליה ברכתא ואמרו כל כהן המברך מתברך.[iii] ומאשר הצענו נבין ג״כ טעם לנטילת ידים אחר קבורת המת[iv] כאשר יתבאר במקומו עוד. וכן לכל הדברים דאמור רבנן דצריכים נטילה אשר הביאם מהרר״י קארו בסימן

Hands that are defiled[2] are unfit for blessing as they are secondary to impurity.[B] And when they are pure, they are secondary to blessing,[C] for blessing rests only upon purity, and the priest, who is a pure man,[3] a man of kindness—blessing rests upon him.[D] And they said: "Any priest who blesses is himself blessed." From what we have presented, we can also understand the reason for washing hands after the burial of the dead, as will be explained in its proper place further on. And so too for all the matters that our Rabbis said require washing, which were brought by Rabbi Joseph Karo[4] in Section 4.

[A] Or: "the likeness of Zeir Anpin" — The term 'דיוקנא' in kabbalistic texts often carries the specific meaning of 'likeness' or 'configuration' rather than simply 'image', which better captures its technical meaning in this context.

[B] Or: "second-degree carriers of impurity" — This alternative more explicitly conveys the technical halakhic concept of 'second-degree impurity' (sheni l'tumah), which refers to objects or hands that have become impure through contact with something that was itself impure.

[C] Or: "vessels for blessing" — This alternative may better convey the intended meaning that hands serve as conduits or instruments through which blessing flows, rather than being the source of blessing themselves.

[D] Or: "divine blessing dwells upon him" — This alternative captures the mystical connotation of 'sharia' (dwelling/resting) in kabbalistic contexts, suggesting the indwelling of divine presence rather than just a beneficial state.

[1] The text connects the priority system for Torah reading aliyot with kabbalistic concepts. 'Zeir Anpin' (the 'Small Face' or 'Lesser Countenance') is a kabbalistic term for a configuration of six divine attributes that serve as a mediating force between the higher divine realms and our world.

[2] The original text begins mid-sentence, continuing a discussion about ritually impure hands.

[3] In Jewish tradition, priests (kohanim) are associated with the divine attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness) and are required to maintain higher levels of ritual purity.

[4] Rabbi Joseph Karo (1488-1575) was the author of the Shulchan Aruch, the most widely accepted code of Jewish law. The text references his compilation of situations requiring hand washing.

[i] This term refers to a second-degree ritual impurity in Jewish law. The concept is that certain impurities can be transferred through multiple stages, with each stage being a lower level of impurity.

[ii] This creates a parallel structure with 'secondary to impurity,' suggesting that hands have a similar relationship to blessing as they do to impurity—they are vessels or conduits rather than the primary source.

[iii] A Talmudic saying (Sotah 38b) that refers specifically to the Priestly Blessing, stating that a priest who blesses the people will himself be blessed.

[iv] This refers to the Jewish practice of washing hands after attending a burial, a ritual purification that serves as a transition from the realm of death back to the realm of life.

175 [ii] [i] :ד׳

פרק ל״ו

Chapter 36

פה יתבאר למה נחום אבלים הוא בברכת המזון[iii] ולא בתפלה או במקום אחר ואמרי׳ במדרש ויקרא רבה פ׳ כ״ג ר׳ יונה הוה מליף לתלמידיו ברכת אבלים אמר הוה גברין בהם.[iv] ממה שמתבאר בפ׳ ויקהל הודיע לנו כי בשעת ברכת המזון הוא עת שמחה ורצון[v] דאמר מאן דמבריך לקודשא בריך הוא מגו שבעא בעי לשואה רעותיה בחדוה ולא ישתכח עציב וכמה דהוא מברך בחדוה ובעינא טבא הכי יהבין ליה בחדוה ובעינא טבא ובגין כך לא ישתכח עציב כלל אלא בחדוה ובמלין דאורייתא וישוי רעותיה למיהב ברכה לאתר דאצטריך דארבע רתיכין שלטין בארבע סטרין אתזנו מההיא ברכתא דשבעא[vi] ומאינון מלין דברוך אתה אתהני ואתרבי ואתדכי בהו.

Here it will be explained why comforting mourners occurs during Grace After Meals (Birkat HaMazon) and not during prayer or elsewhere. In Midrash Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 23, it is stated that Rabbi Yonah would teach his students the blessing for 5R
mourners, saying, “Be men in them.” From what is explained in Parashat Vayakhel,[1] we learn that the time of the Grace After Meals is a time of joy and divine favor, as it states: “One who blesses the Holy One, blessed be He, after being satisfied 10R
should direct their intention with joy and should not be found sad. And just as one blesses with joy and a good eye, so too will they receive in return with joy and a good eye. Therefore, one should not be found sad at all, but rather joyful 15R
and engaged in words of Torah, and should direct their intention to bestow blessing where it is needed. The four celestial chariots that govern the four directions[2] are nourished from that blessing of satisfaction, and from those words of ‘Blessed are 20R
You,’ they benefit, increase, and are purified. On weekdays, they benefit from those words that ascend

[1] The text refers to a section of the Zohar (the primary text of Jewish mysticism) on the Torah portion Vayakhel. This is not the biblical text itself but the mystical commentary on it.

[2] This refers to a kabbalistic concept where four angelic forces (sometimes associated with the four archangels: Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Uriel) govern the four directions of the universe and channel divine energy.

[i] This refers to section 4 of the Shulchan Aruch (Code of Jewish Law), which lists various situations requiring ritual hand washing.

[ii] Cf. Ma’avar Yabok — This passage refers to a later section in Ma’avar Yabok that discusses ritual purification after contact with the dead in greater detail, showing how the author structured the work with internal cross-references. | Cf. Talmud Sotah 38b — The phrase ‘any priest who blesses is himself blessed’ is a direct quote from this Talmudic passage, which discusses the reciprocal nature of blessing. | Cf. Shulchan Aruch — The reference to ‘Section 4’ points to the specific part of Rabbi Joseph Karo’s code of Jewish law that enumerates situations requiring ritual hand washing. | Cf. Zohar — The kabbalistic conception that ‘blessing rests only upon purity’ reflects numerous Zoharic teachings about the relationship between ritual purity and divine influence.

[iii] The opening phrase signals this is a thematic section explaining the mystical reasons why the consolation of mourners occurs specifically during the Grace After Meals rather than during other prayer services.

[iv] The original Hebrew refers to a somewhat obscure saying of Rabbi Yonah who taught his disciples about the blessing for mourners, telling them to ‘be men in them’ (possibly meaning to be strong or show appropriate dignity in performing these rituals).

[v] The Hebrew terms ‘simcha v’ratzon’ (joy and favor/will) are technical terms in Kabbalah referring to a state of spiritual receptivity when divine influence flows more freely.

[vi] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar describes how the ‘four chariots ruling in the four directions’ receive nourishment from the blessing over food. These ‘chariots’ (merkavot/retichin) refer to angelic forces that govern different aspects of creation.

ובחול אתהני מגו אינון מלין
דסלקין מגו שבעא וכלהו שבעין
ורוון בחידו. בשבת אתהני
ממזונא ממש ובההוא חדוה
דמזונא דמצוה: ולכן טוב עין
הוא יברך וינחם בברכת הטוב
והמטיב שהוא סוף התפשטות
הברכה במלכות[i] מלבד מה
שהופיע עליו רחמים גדולים
בברכת המזון שנברך שאכלנו
משלו הוא בעלמא עילאה דלא
ידיע ואין שם תפיסה לכן מדבר
שלא לנוכח דמזוני ממזלא
עילאה נינהו ואוצרם הוא
בהוד[ii] כנודע ושם אמר נברך
וברוך מנחם אבלים שאכלנו
משלו ובזה יתברך ויתנחם
מבחינת הראש והסוף ואמרו
כי המברך ברכת המזון ברצון
ובשמחת הלב בשמסתלק מן
העולם מקום מתוקן לו למעלה
בסוד עליון בהיכלות קדושות
ולכן אמרו כי גדול מברך.
וכהן ת״ח לו נאה לברך להיותו
מצד החסד כי כן צד ימין מוכן
להאיר לעולם. ולכן הכהן מוכן
לברך מעלה ומטה ובעת ברכת
כהנים ברכות מהמקור העליון
מדליקין הנרות ומאירים כל
הפנים וכנסת ישראל מתעטרת

from satisfaction, and all are satisfied and saturated with joy. On the Sabbath, they benefit from the actual food and from the joy of the food of the commandment." 25R

Therefore, one with a good eye will bless and comfort during the blessing of "Who is good and does good" (HaTov VehaMeitiv), which is the final extension of blessing into Malkhut[1] (Kingdom). This is in addition to the great mercy that shines upon him during the Grace After Meals when we say "let us bless the One from whose bounty we have eaten," which refers to the supernal world that is not known and cannot be grasped. For this reason, we speak in the third person rather than directly addressing God, because sustenance comes from the supernal mazal[2] (celestial influence), and its storehouse is in Hod[3] (Splendor), as is known. And there we say, "Let us bless" and "Blessed is the One who comforts mourners, from whose bounty we have eaten." Through this, the mourner receives blessing and comfort from both the beginning and the end of the prayer. 30R 35R 40R

It is said that one who recites the Grace After Meals with willingness and joy of heart, when they depart from this world, a place is prepared for them above in the supernal mystery, in the holy chambers. Therefore, they said that the most distinguished person should lead the blessing. And a learned priest (kohen talmid chacham)[4] is most fitting to bless, since he is from the side of Chesed[5] (Loving- 45R 50R

[1] In Kabbalah, Malkhut (Kingdom) is the tenth and lowest of the divine emanations (sefirot), representing God's presence in the physical world. This blessing is seen as completing the circuit of divine energy through all the sefirot.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, 'mazal' here doesn't refer to fortune or luck as in common usage, but to a high spiritual source that channels divine abundance. Specifically, it often refers to the influence flowing from the sefirah of Binah (Understanding).

[3] Hod (Splendor) is the eighth of the ten divine emanations (sefirot) in Kabbalah. The text identifies it as the spiritual storehouse for sustenance, representing the divine attribute that channels abundance to the physical world.

[4] The original text uses the abbreviation 't"ch' for 'talmid chacham' (Torah scholar). The author argues that a priest who is also a Torah scholar is especially suited to lead the blessing because he combines both ritual status (priesthood) and spiritual wisdom.

[5] In Kabbalah, priests (kohanim) are associated with the divine attribute of Chesed (Loving-kindness), which is positioned on the right side of the kabbalistic Tree of Life diagram. This explains their suitability for blessing others.

[i] The text refers to Malkhut (Kingdom), the lowest of the ten divine sefirot in Kabbalah, which represents the divine presence in the material world. The blessing 'HaTov VehaMeitiv' is described as the final extension of divine blessing into this lowest sefirah.

[ii] This is a kabbalistic teaching that sustenance comes from the 'supernal mazal' (a high spiritual source) and is stored in the sefirah of Hod (Splendor). This reflects the belief that physical sustenance has spiritual sources in higher worlds.

בעטרות עליונים. ואמרי׳ שבכל
מקום שתשרה השפעת הימין
עין הרע אינו שולט בו וכל
ברכת המזון הוא בימין ואין
שטן ואין פגע רע לבן מנחמים
האבל בו וצריך לומר בברכת
המזון וקידוש והבדלה ובברכת
אירוסין ונשואין סברי מרנן והם
עונין לחיים להורות כי נקשרים
באילן החיים יין המשמח לא
באילן דמות שהוא גפן שחטא בה
אדם הראשון[i] כך כתוב בתקון
כ״ד: ושמעתי הטעם שהוא לפי
שהיו משברים בקורט לבונה
שמשימים תוך היין למי שהיה
חייב מיתת ב״ד[ii] אחר שהתודה
כדכתיב תנו שכר לאובד וגו׳
ובהשקות אותו היו אומרים סבר
מרנן והם עונין למיתה. ואולי
יהיה זה לשאול למחייבי׳ אם
עדיין עומדים בטעמם לחייבו
כי אם מצאו לו זכות פטרוהו.
והם משיבים כי בשמועתם
עומדים. ולכן עתה עונין לחיים.
עוד נאמר כי ברשות רבותי
שאומרים קודם המוציא וכן
סברי שאומרים על היין להיותו
באמצע הסעודה הוא מדבר עם
כחות הקדושה המזדמנים שם
לקבל אותם ברכה[iii] ולהיות
ברכת היין חשובה על כן
מנהג להזמין השומעים תחלה
שיתקדשו לקבל רוחניות הברכה
ההיא וכבר נודע טעם שכתבו

kindness), as the right side is ready to illuminate the world. Therefore, the priest is prepared to bless both above and below, and at the time of the Priestly Blessing, blessings from the supernal source cause the lamps to be lit and all faces to shine, and the Congregation of Israel is crowned with supernal crowns. 55R

It is said that wherever the influence of the right side rests, the evil eye has no power, and the entire Grace After Meals is associated with the right side, so there is no adversary and no evil occurrence. Therefore, we comfort the mourner during it. One must say before the Grace After Meals, Kiddush, Havdalah, and the blessings of betrothal and marriage, "With your permission, my masters" (Savrei Maranan), and they respond "To life" (L'chaim), indicating that they are connecting to the Tree of Life, the wine that gladdens, and not to the tree of death,[1] which is the vine that Adam sinned with, as written in Tikkun 24. 60R 65R 70R

I have heard that the reason for this is that they used to give a grain of frankincense placed in wine[2] to those condemned to death by the court after they had confessed, as it is written, "Give strong drink to the one who is perishing, etc." When giving him to drink, they would say, "With your permission, my masters," and they would respond "To death." Perhaps this was to ask the judges if they still maintained their reasoning to condemn him, for if they had found merit for him, they would have acquitted him. And they respond that they stand by their judgment. Therefore, now we respond "To life." 75R 80R

It may also be said that "With your permission, my masters" (Birshut Rabotai), which is said be- 85R

[1] This reflects a kabbalistic interpretation that identifies wine with both positive and negative spiritual potentials. When used properly in ritual contexts, wine connects to the Tree of Life; when abused, it connects to death and judgment.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic practice (Sanhedrin 43a) of giving condemned prisoners drugged wine before execution to dull their senses, which the author connects to the ritual formula used before blessing wine.

[i] This reflects a kabbalistic interpretation that identifies the forbidden fruit of the Garden of Eden as grapes/wine. The text contrasts this 'tree of death' with the 'Tree of Life,' linking the ritual response 'L'chaim' (to life) with this mystical concept.

[ii] The text describes an ancient practice of giving frankincense-infused wine to those condemned to death by the court, referring to the talmudic custom of providing intoxicating drink to dull the pain of execution.

[iii] The text explains that when saying formulas like 'Savrei Maranan' (With your permission, masters), one is actually addressing spiritual forces or angels that gather to receive the blessing, not merely the human participants.

הפוסקים על זה ומנייהו לא נזוע
והקהל עונים לחיים שרומזים
לחיות המתפשט בספירות
דעלמא דדכורא[i] וברשות רבותי
המסובין עונין ברשות שמים גם
הם מאמתים שצריך ליטול רשות
מהכתות העליונים ולהזמינם
שיבואו לענות אמן אחר הברכה
והקדושה ההיא ולהריחה ריח
ניחוח לה׳. ועל הפת שהוא
מן הארץ מקום תחלת הכניסה
לקדושה אומרים ברשות רבותי
ושם הוא סוד שפע הנקרא אכילה
כי בהתעוררותם מסלקין ומעלין
שפע לרעים דלא מתפרשן
לעלמין[ii] ועל היין שמקורו
מן סוד עץ החיים אומרים
סברי מרנן דסבי עצה וטעמא
וסברא[iii] ומשם ממעלה למטה
יורד השפע לדודין תהאין[iv] וזהו
שתו ושכרו דודים וזה יהיה
לדעתי כוונת האומר מרשים
על הפת וסברין על היין ובעל
הלבושים נתן טעמים לזה לפי
דרכו[v] והבורר יברור לעצמו.
וכל קדושה שהיא על היין צריך
ברכה וקדושה וכן השבת ג״כ.
על כן בקבלת שבת אומרים ב׳

fore Hamotzi (blessing over bread), and "With your permission, my masters" (Savrei Maranan), which is said over wine when it is in the middle of the meal, is addressing the holy forces that gather there to receive those blessings. Since the blessing over wine is important, it is customary to invite the listeners first to sanctify themselves to receive the spirituality of that blessing. The reason that the legal authorities have given for this is already known, and from their explanations we do not depart. The congregation responds "To life," alluding to the life-force that extends through the sefirot of the masculine realm.[1] And to "With your permission, my masters," those reclining respond "With Heaven's permission," also affirming that one must seek permission from the supernal hosts and invite them to come answer "Amen" after that blessing and sanctification, and to receive it as a pleasing fragrance to the Lord.

For bread, which comes from the earth—the place where one first enters into holiness—we say "With your permission, my masters" (Birshut Rabotai), and there lies the secret of the flow called "eating," for through their arousal they elevate and raise the flow to "friends who never separate."[2] And for wine, whose source is from the mystery of the Tree of Life, we say "With your permission, my masters" (Savrei Maranan), who possess counsel, reason, and understanding,[3] and

[1]The 'masculine realm' (alma d'dikhura) in Kabbalah refers to the upper divine attributes, particularly Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) and those above it, which are characterized by giving and bestowing rather than receiving.

[2]This is a technical kabbalistic term (re'im d'lo mitparshin l'almin) referring to divine attributes that remain in perpetual unity. The blessing over bread is understood to channel divine energy to these unified spiritual forces.

[3]The author is making a wordplay on 'savrei' (with your permission) by connecting it to 'sevara' (reasoning/understanding), suggesting that the formula addresses both human leaders and celestial forces of wisdom.

[i]The phrase 'alma d'dikhura' (masculine realm) is a kabbalistic term referring to the upper sefirot associated with masculine divine qualities, particularly Tiferet (Beauty). The response 'L'chaim' is said to connect to this spiritual life-force.

[ii]This Aramaic phrase refers to 'friends who never separate'—a kabbalistic term for the divine attributes that remain in constant unity. The blessing over bread is said to elevate divine flow to these unified attributes.

[iii]The author provides a wordplay on 'savrei' (with your permission) connecting it to 'sevara' (reasoning/understanding), suggesting that the formula addresses those who possess wisdom and understanding.

[iv]The phrase 'dodin tata'in' (lower beloved ones) is a kabbalistic term referring to the union of masculine and feminine divine attributes in the lower worlds. Wine is described as facilitating this spiritual union.

[v]The 'Ba'al HaLevushim' refers to Rabbi Mordechai Jaffe (1530-1612), author of the halakhic work Levush Malkhut, indicating that the author is aware of alternate explanations for these customs.

פעמים בואי כלה בואי כלה נגד קול חתן וקול כלה.[i] ועיין בתקון מ״ז דף פ״ז מתקוני השלחן באורך:[ii]

from there, from above to below, the flow descends to the lower beloved ones,[1] and this is "drink and be intoxicated, O beloved ones." This, in my opinion, is the intention behind saying "With permission" for bread and "With your consent" for wine. The author of the Levushim[2] gave explanations for this according to his approach, and one who selects may choose for himself.

Every sanctification that is over wine requires blessing and sanctification, and so too the Sabbath. Therefore, in welcoming the Sabbath we say twice "Come, O bride! Come, O bride!" corresponding to "the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride." See Tikkun 47, page 87, regarding the arrangements of the table at length.

פרק ל״ז

Chapter 37

נמצא כתוב בדברי חכמים כי ההולך לגמול חסדים כגון בקור חולים והכנסת כלה והוצאת המת וניחום אבלים וכיוצא יוליך בניו עמו[iii] וזה

It is written in the words of the sages that one who goes to perform acts of kindness,[3] such as visiting the sick, attending to a bride, accompanying the dead, comforting mourners, and similar deeds, should take his children with him. This is because, beyond teach-

[1] The phrase 'lower beloved ones' (dodin tata'in) is a kabbalistic term for the union of masculine and feminine divine energies in the lower worlds, particularly the union of Tiferet and Malkhut.

[2] This refers to Rabbi Mordechai Jaffe (1530-1612), author of Levush Malkhut, a comprehensive code of Jewish law. The author acknowledges that Jaffe provides different explanations for these customs than the mystical ones being presented here.

[3] The text lists five specific acts of kindness (gemilut chasadim) that are considered particularly meritorious in Jewish tradition: visiting the sick, attending to a bride, accompanying the dead, comforting mourners, and similar deeds. These are not merely social obligations but actions with cosmic significance in the kabbalistic worldview.

[i] The text explains that the double repetition of 'Come, O bride' in the Sabbath welcoming service (Kabbalat Shabbat) corresponds to the biblical phrase 'the voice of the bridegroom and the voice of the bride,' establishing a parallel between Sabbath observance and marriage.

[ii] Cf. Midrash Vayikra Rabbah, chapter 23 — The text cites this midrash as a source for the practice of comforting mourners during the Grace After Meals, showing that this practice has ancient rabbinic roots. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The passage quotes extensively from the Zohar on Vayakhel regarding the spiritual significance of the Grace After Meals, explaining how it affects higher spiritual realms and channels divine blessing. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Tikkun 24 — The text references this section of Tikkunei Zohar regarding the mystical significance of wine, contrasting the 'wine that gladdens' with the 'vine that Adam sinned with,' establishing the kabbalistic framework for why we say 'L'chaim' (to life). | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Tikkun 47 — The author refers readers to this section for further elaboration on the mystical arrangements of the table, indicating that there is deeper kabbalistic significance to these meal rituals than what is explained in the current passage. | Cf. Proverbs 31:6 — The text cites this verse to explain the historical practice of giving wine with frankincense to condemned prisoners, which serves as the background for the ritual formula 'Savrei Maranan' (With your permission, my masters). | Cf. Song of Songs 5:1 — The text alludes to this verse from Song of Songs to explain the mystical significance of wine in ritual contexts, connecting it to divine love and spiritual nourishment.

[iii] The text emphasizes the educational value of bringing children along when performing acts of kindness, serving both to teach them compassion and to effect cosmic unification between different spiritual levels.

כי מלבד שמחנכם לגמול חסד.
עוד מקביל ליחד חיות קטנות
עם גדולות[i] דאית חיה זוטרתי
וזוטרתי דזוטרתי וחיה סתם
בעשיה וביצירה ובבריאה עוד
יבחנו למעלה באצילות[ii] ואז
ודאי ישבעו עצי ה׳ וגו׳ ופי׳
בזהר פ׳ שמות דף ע״ב בסוד ז׳
הבלים[iii] שזכרנו למעלה דאינון
הם עמודים סמכין דעלמא לקבל
ז׳ רקיעים ואמר כי יש הבלים
אחרים המתפשטים מהבלים
אלו וכלם מתקיימים ומתחזקים
במעשה התחתונים ובהתעוררות
העולה מן הארץ וזהו יש הבל
אשר נעשה על הארץ וכל
תקפא וקיומא דיליה בנשמתהון
דצדיקיא דאתלקיטו מארעא
כד אינון זכאין ועיין בתקון ס״ט
דף ק״ו במעשה דההוא בעל
קבין בשבעה היכלות שבנה בז׳
הבלים אלו. ואמרי׳ במדרש
קהלת על פסוק סוף דבר הכל
נשמע בשעה שאדם נפטר מן
העולם הקב״ה אומר למלאכי
השרת ראו מה הבריות אומרות
עליו בשר היה ירא שמים היה
פלוני זה מיד מטתו פורחת
באויר[iv] כדאמרי׳ במדרש שיר
השירים ברבי אושעיא איש
טריא ואומר הקב״ה חביב עלי

ing them to perform kindness, it also corresponds to uniting small living beings with large ones,[1] for there are minor living beings, and even smaller ones, and ordinary living beings in the worlds of Asiyah (Action), Yetzirah (Formation), and Beriah (Creation), and they will be further examined above in Atzilut (Emanation),[2] and then surely "the trees of the LORD shall be satisfied" etc. The Zohar explains in Parashat Shemot (page 72) regarding the secret of the seven "breaths" that we mentioned above,[3] that they are pillars supporting the world, corresponding to the seven firmaments. It states that there are other "breaths" that extend from these breaths, and all are sustained and strengthened through the actions of those below and through the awakening that rises from the earth. This is the meaning of "there is a breath that is made upon the earth," and all its power and existence depend on the souls of the righteous who are gathered from the earth when they are meritorious. See also in Tikkun 69, page 106, the story of that crippled man in the seven palaces that he built through these seven breaths.

10R 15R 20R 25R

And it is said in the Midrash Kohelet on the verse "The end of the matter, all is heard"—when a person departs from the world, the Holy One, blessed be He, says to the ministering angels, "See what the people say about him: Was he flesh? Was he God-fearing? Was he this particular person?" Immediately his bed floats in the air, as is said in the Midrash Shir HaShirim regarding Rabbi Oshaya of Tirya. And the Holy One, blessed be He, says, "He is as beloved to

30R 35R

[1] This should be understood metaphorically as referring to the unification of spiritual entities or forces across different cosmic levels, not literally as bringing together physical creatures of different sizes.

[2] These are the four worlds of kabbalistic cosmology, arranged hierarchically from lowest to highest: Asiyah (Action), Yetzirah (Formation), Beriah (Creation), and Atzilut (Emanation). The text suggests that performing acts of kindness creates unifications across all these levels.

[3] The Hebrew word 'havalim' (breaths/vanities) is reinterpreted from its usage in Ecclesiastes (where it connotes futility) into a positive kabbalistic concept of divine emanations or cosmic forces that sustain creation.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of unifying different levels of spiritual entities ('living beings') across the cosmic structure, not merely to physical creatures of different sizes.

[ii] The text describes a hierarchical cosmology of four worlds (Asiyah, Yetzirah, Beriah, and Atzilut), with spiritual entities ('living beings') existing at each level and being 'examined' or integrated upward through the system.

[iii] These 'seven breaths' (havalim) refer to a kabbalistic concept derived from Ecclesiastes, where the word 'hevel' (vanity/breath) appears seven times. In kabbalah, these are reinterpreted as seven divine emanations that sustain creation.

[iv] The miraculous floating of the deathbed in the air is a symbolic representation of the soul's elevation and the deceased's spiritual worthiness, not merely a physical miracle.

הוא ככל ישראל וזהו כי זה כל האדם. ואמר בפ׳ בשלח דף מ״ז ובכלא בעי לאחזאה עובדא ולאתערא אתערותא ממה דאצטריך ובתקון ס״ט דף קי״א ביאר מוצא נשמות קדושות מהבל ובלתי קדושות מקין[i] ומעט טוביות שהיה בקין נתפשט עד קני חותן משה ומשם ואילך היה התפשטות הרע כי כן יש הבל הקדוש והבל מסטרא אחרא דהוא הבל ורעות רוח כי זה לעומת זה עשה האלהים. הנה כי העושה חסד עם גופות ונפשות הצדיקים הוא מתקן ז׳ הבלים עליונים ומהפכן מלהב להבל מדין לרחמים[ii] ומריק עליהם משבעה מוצקות הנרות אשר ע״י ראשם ומן השנים הזתי״ם אשר על ראש המנורה[iii] א׳ מימין וא׳ משמאל הגולה העליונה שעל ראשם והוא ישכון בטח ושאנן ובצל שדי יתלונן:[iv]

Me as all of Israel," and this is the meaning of "for this is the whole of man."

And it is said in Parashat Beshalach, page 47, "In all things one must demonstrate action and arouse awakening from what is needed." And in Tikkun 69, page 111, it explains that holy souls originate from Abel and unholy ones from Cain,[1] and the small amount of goodness that was in Cain extended until Keni, Moses' father-in-law, and from there onward was the extension of evil, for indeed there is holy breath and breath from the "Other Side," which is breath and vexation of spirit, for "God has made one thing opposite the other."

Thus, one who performs kindness with the bodies and souls of the righteous repairs the seven supernal "breaths" and transforms them from flame to breath, from judgment to mercy,[2] and pours upon them from the seven branches of the lamps that are upon their heads, and from the two olive trees that are upon the head of the menorah,[3] one on the right and one on the left of the upper bowl that is upon their heads, and he will dwell in security and tranquility and abide in the shadow of the Almighty.[4]

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the biblical figures of Cain and Abel represent archetypal spiritual sources from which different types of souls originate, explaining the spiritual diversity among humans.

[2] The Hebrew contains a wordplay between 'lahav' (flame) and 'hevel' (breath) that cannot be fully captured in English. This wordplay emphasizes the transformative power of kindness to convert harsh judgment (symbolized by consuming fire) into merciful sustenance (symbolized by life-giving breath).

[3] This imagery draws on the vision in Zechariah 4:1-14 of a golden menorah with seven lamps, fed by two olive trees. In kabbalistic interpretation, this represents the structure of divine emanation and the channels through which divine mercy flows into creation.

[4] The conclusion emphasizes the personal spiritual benefit of performing acts of kindness—those

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that souls have different spiritual origins—righteous souls originating from Abel (Hevel) and unrighteous souls from Cain (Kayin), establishing a spiritual genealogy of souls.

[ii] This is a significant wordplay in Hebrew between 'lahav' (flame) and 'hevel' (breath), indicating the mystical transformation of harsh judgment into mercy through acts of kindness. The similar sounds of these words are meaningful in the kabbalistic tradition.

[iii] This imagery draws on Zechariah's vision (4:1-14) of the menorah with seven lamps and two olive trees, which in kabbalah represents the structure of divine emanation and the flow of spiritual energy.

[iv] Cf. Ecclesiastes 1:2 — The text reinterprets the concept of 'hevel' (breath/vanity) from Ecclesiastes in a positive, mystical sense as divine emanations or 'breaths' that sustain the cosmos, rather than in its plain meaning of futility or meaninglessness. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shemot, page 72 — The Zohar passage is cited to explain the cosmological significance of the seven 'breaths' or emanations that support the universe, corresponding to the seven heavens. This reference establishes the mystical framework for understanding how human actions affect spiritual realms. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Tikkun 69 — This reference to Tikkunei Zohar brings in the symbolic figure of the 'crippled man' (likely representing the kabbalistic concept of restricted divine energy) who nevertheless constructs spiritual palaces through the power of the seven divine 'breaths', showing how limitation can be transcended through proper channeling of spiritual forces. | Cf. Ecclesiastes

60 שפת חסד של אמת[i] תכון
לעד ועד בשחק נאמן סלה[ii] כי
לכבודו עשיתי ומעתה יהיו
תחלת דברי בחלק השלישי
מספר מעבר יבק הלזה אשר
65 יקרא בישראל שמו שפתי
רננות[iii] אלהים יעזרנו על דבר
כבוד שמו אכי״ר:[iv]

The lip of kindness and truth shall be established forever, and a faithful witness in heaven. For I have done this for His glory, and from now on let these be the beginning of my words in the third part of this book Ma'avar Yabok,[1] which shall be called in Israel by the name "Siftei Renanot" (Lips of Joyous Song). May God help us for the sake of the honor of His name,[2] Amen. May it be His will.

60R

65R

who engage in such deeds will themselves receive divine protection and blessing, completing a cycle of giving and receiving that maintains cosmic harmony.

[1]The title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Yabok) refers to Jacob's biblical crossing of the Yabok River, which serves as a metaphor for the soul's transition from this world to the next—a central theme of the book.

[2]The formal, doxological ending of this introduction reflects standard practice in Jewish religious works, where authors express humility and acknowledge divine assistance in their scholarly endeavors.

12:13 — This verse from the conclusion of Ecclesiastes is reinterpreted in a mystical context to describe what happens after death—how the Holy One gathers information about the deceased from what people say about them, which determines their ultimate spiritual status. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach, page 47 — This Zohar reference establishes the kabbalistic principle that actions in the physical world ('arousal from below') are necessary to stimulate corresponding spiritual responses ('arousal from above'), which is central to the text's argument about the cosmic significance of acts of kindness. | Cf. Genesis 4 — The text reinterprets the biblical story of Cain and Abel in kabbalistic terms, seeing them as archetypal sources of different qualities of souls—holy ones from Abel and unholy ones from Cain—establishing a mystical genealogy of souls that explains spiritual differences among humans. | Cf. Psalm 104:16 — This psalm verse is reinterpreted in a kabbalistic context to refer to the satisfaction of divine emanations (represented as 'trees') when proper unification occurs between various levels of spiritual reality through human acts of kindness. | Cf. Zechariah 4:1-14 — The text draws on Zechariah's vision of the golden menorah with seven lamps and two olive trees to create a visual metaphor for how acts of kindness channel divine mercy through cosmic structures, transforming judgment into compassion.

[i]This phrase combines Proverbs 12:19 ('truthful lip shall be established forever') with the rabbinic concept of 'chesed shel emet' (true kindness), which specifically refers to kindness toward the dead who cannot repay the favor.

[ii]A reference to Psalm 89:38, 'the faithful witness in the sky,' which in this context refers to the eternal nature of divine truth.

[iii]The title of this third section of Ma'avar Yabok means 'Lips of Joyous Song' or 'Lips of Praise,' suggesting that this section will focus on prayers and praises related to death and the afterlife.

[iv]An acronym for 'Amen Ken Yehi Ratzon' (Amen, So May It Be His Will), a traditional closing formula for prayers.

Discourse 5

שפתי רננות / Lips of Joyous Song

פרק א׳

Chapter 1

כמו חלב ודשן [i] תשבע נפשי.
ושפתי רננות [ii] יהלל פי. ה׳
שפתי תפתח [iii] ופי יגיד תהלתך
בעה״ז ובעה״ב [iv] אמן כי״ר: [v] [vi]

Like fat and rich food[1] my soul will be satisfied. And my lips of joy[2] will praise You. O LORD, open my lips, that my mouth may declare Your praise in this world and in the World to Come,[3] Amen, may it be Your will. 5R

ברם יזכה אדם את ארחו לעמוד
לשרת לפני מלכו רק לידע

Indeed, a person may purify his path to stand and serve before his King[4] only by knowing and making

[1] This metaphor expresses spiritual fulfillment and satisfaction through divine connection, rather than literal physical nourishment.
[2] The Hebrew phrase 'siftei renanot' has special significance as it also names the third discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, creating a self-referential connection within the work.
[3] This phrase reflects the book's central concern with both proper religious practice in this life and its consequences in the afterlife.
[4] This opening echoes Psalm 119:9 ('How can a young man purify his path?') while introducing the theme of spiritual service.

[i] This is a reference to Psalm 63:6, expressing spiritual satisfaction through divine connection.
[ii] The phrase 'lips of joy/praise' connects to the book's third section titled 'Siftei Renanot' (Lips of Joyous Song/Praise) mentioned in the outline.
[iii] This is a direct quote from Psalm 51:17, which is traditionally recited at the beginning of the Amidah prayer.
[iv] Abbreviation for 'ba-olam ha-zeh u-va-olam ha-ba,' meaning 'in this world and in the World to Come.'
[v] Abbreviation for 'ken yehi ratzon' (may it be [Your] will), a common closing formula for prayers.
[vi] Cf. Psalm 63:6 — The author opens with this psalm reference to establish the spiritual satisfaction that comes from proper devotion and prayer, setting the tone for the entire work's focus on spiritual preparation. | Cf. Psalm 51:17 — By incorporating this verse that begins the Amidah prayer, the author frames the entire work as a form of divine service, positioning his guidance on death rituals as an extension of established liturgical practice. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse Three ('Siftei Renanot') — The phrase 'siftei renanot' (lips of joy) creates an internal cross-reference to the third discourse of the book itself, suggesting that proper prayer and praise form a unified theme throughout the work's approach to death and dying.

ולהודיע כי פעולת הדברים הגשמיים כלם להם מבא ורמז בדברים הרוחניים ושלמותם הוא בהאחז הפעולה הגשמית ברוחנית כדי שיתעורר השרש הנעלם הרוחני ע״י הענף החצון הגשמי לכן הוצרך אל כל פעולה גשמית יתלוה אליה דבר נעלם ורוחני. וזהו סוד הברכה על מעשה המצות שיתלוה עם המעשה הגשמי הרוחני שהוא הדבור והבל פה. ולמעלה מזה עוד המחשבה בדבור ההוא. הקדמה זו למד אותנו החכם קורדואיר״ו זצ״ל בדרושיו המופלאים.[i] ומעשה המצות הגשמי יעלה עניינה במקום העשיה לבד שבו מקום שמקבלות הנפשות אחר מנוחתם שכרם והוא לבוש מתהוה ממעשה המצות הגשמיות ומצד העשייה נוטל שכרו גם הגוף העושה בפירות והקרן קיימת לו לעה״ב.[ii] וזהו מצד הנפש שהיא מצד העשיה והדבור שהוא הבל פה הוא במקום היצירה ששם מנוחת הרוחות והקולות ומהדבורים נעשה להם לבוש והיינו חלוקא דרבנן בג״ע מקום מנוחת הרוחות[iii] ומהמחשבה שהיא דקה ביותר והוא חלק השכל מורכב על הדבור והמעשה נעשה לבוש לנשמות במקום הבריאה ששם תשובת הנשמות אחר פטירתם מהגוף. וג׳ חלקים אלו הם חלקי הגוף וזה כל

known that all physical actions have an entry point and allusion in spiritual matters. Their perfection lies in connecting the physical action with the spiritual, so that the hidden spiritual root is awakened through the external physical branch. Therefore, every physical action requires that something hidden and spiritual accompany it. This is the secret of the blessing over the performance of commandments—that the spiritual, which is speech and the breath of the mouth, accompanies the physical action. And beyond this is the thought within that speech. This introduction was taught to us by the sage Cordovero, of blessed memory, in his wondrous discourses.

The physical performance of commandments elevates its essence only to the realm of Asiyah (Action),[1] where souls receive their reward after their rest. This becomes a garment formed from the physical performance of commandments. Through the aspect of Asiyah, even the body that performs receives its reward in "fruits," while the "principal" remains for the World to Come. This corresponds to the nefesh (vital soul), which relates to the realm of Asiyah. Speech, which is the breath of the mouth, exists in the realm of Yetzirah (Formation), where spirits and voices rest. From these utterances, a garment is formed for them, which is the "scholarly garment" in the Garden of Eden,[2] the resting place of spirits. From thought, which is the most refined and is the portion of the intellect built upon speech and action, a garment is made for the neshamot (higher souls) in the realm of Beriah (Creation), where the souls return after departing from the body.

These three parts constitute the components of the body, and this is the whole person. Therefore, blessings were instituted for the performance of commandments so that through the blessing, one turns

[1] The author is establishing a hierarchical structure where different types of religious activity affect different cosmic levels, with physical actions affecting only the lowest world (Asiyah).

[2] The concept of 'chaluka d'rabbanan' (scholarly garment) appears frequently in kabbalistic literature as the spiritual vestment souls receive in the afterlife based on their Torah study and good deeds.

[i] This refers to Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), a leading kabbalist in Safed who authored Pardes Rimmonim, a systematic presentation of Kabbalah that significantly influenced later mystical thought.

[ii] This refers to the rabbinic concept that certain commandments provide 'fruits' (benefits) in this world while the 'principal' (main reward) remains for the World to Come, as mentioned in the Mishnah (Peah 1:1).

[iii] This term refers to the 'scholarly garment,' a metaphysical vestment that souls receive in the afterlife, formed from their Torah study and good deeds in this world.

האדם על כן תקנו הברכות על
מעשה המצות כדי שע״י הברכה
יפנה למעלה ויזכה אל תקון
שלשה חלקים אלו. וכן בתפלות
שהם דבור ומחשבה לבד תקנו
שיתלוה אליהם המעשה בתפילין
וציצית וגם בפעולות גשמיות
תקנו ברכות כמו ברכות השחר
וכיוצא תקנו ברכה כדי שע״י
הפעולה ההיא תזכה הרוח
והנשמה. עוד תקנו לתת תודה
לקונו על כל הפעולת גשמיות
שע״י התורה הפעולה גשמית
נעשית רוחנית ונמצא זוכה
בעצמו וזוכה אל הרוח והנשמה
ואחר שהרוח והנשמה יש להם
שכר טוב בעמל הגשמי ממילא
נמשך חלק אל הנפש. וזה כולל
בכל הברכות וההודאות ואפי׳
האכילה אם יכוין ליהנות ולזון
נפשו מרוחניות הקדוש שבמאכל
ההוא ולהעלותו מדומם וצומח
ובעל חי בלתי מדבר למדרגת
האדם נקרא צדיק אוכל לשובע
נפשו[i] ואם לאו הוא מצד החסרון
והקליפה ועליו נאמר ובטן
רשעים תחסר וזהו בכל דרכיך
אפי׳ הגשמיות דעהו לקב״ה
והדבק בו והוא יישר אורחותיך
הגשמיות לעבודתו כדי שתשיג
האושר האמיתי. וברכה שעל
כל המצות והפעולות היא
המשכת רוחניות מרום המעלות
עד מלכות שבה קבוץ השפע
המקבלת מת״ת. לכן נקרא
כנסת ישראל[ii] ואח״כ משם נמשך
אל התחתונים ולא חוייבנו
להמשיכו אלא בה והיא הנותנת

upward and merits the rectification of these three parts. Similarly, for prayers, which are speech and thought alone, it was established that physical action should accompany them through tefillin and tzitzit. For physical actions as well, blessings were instituted, such as the morning blessings and the like, so that through these actions, the ruach (spirit) and neshamah (higher soul) might merit reward. They further instituted giving thanks to one's Creator for all physical actions, for through Torah, physical action becomes spiritual. Thus, one merits reward personally and also for the ruach and neshamah. And since the ruach and neshamah receive good reward for physical effort, a portion naturally flows to the nefesh as well.

This principle applies to all blessings and thanksgivings. Even eating, if one intends to benefit and nourish one's soul from the holiness within that food,[1] elevating it from inanimate, vegetative, or non-speaking animal states to the level of human, is called "a righteous person eating to satisfy his soul." If not, it stems from deficiency and negative forces, and of such a person it is said, "The belly of the wicked shall lack." This is the meaning of "Know Him in all your ways"—even physical ones—"know the Holy One, blessed be He, cleave to Him, and He will straighten your physical paths for His service," so that you may attain true happiness.

The blessing over all commandments and actions draws spirituality from the highest heights down to Malkhut (Kingdom),[2] where the influx received from Tiferet (Beauty) is gathered. This is why it is called "the Assembly of Israel." Afterward, from there it flows to the lower realms. We are obligated to draw it down only through Malkhut, which "provides food for her household and a portion for her maidens." In every commandment a person performs, one should intend that his soul is being rectified and illuminated

[1] This reflects the Hasidic approach to elevating mundane activities, which expanded on earlier kabbalistic ideas that even eating can be transformed into a spiritual practice through proper intention.

[2] This describes the kabbalistic understanding of divine flow (shefa) descending through the sefirot (divine attributes) until reaching Malkhut, which then distributes this spiritual energy to the lower worlds.

[i] This is a direct quote from Proverbs 13:25, which the author interprets in a mystical sense to mean that righteous people transform even physical eating into a spiritual act.

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic understanding of Malkhut (Kingdom) as the divine attribute that receives influx from Tiferet (Beauty) and is identified with Knesset Israel (the mystical community of Israel).

טרף לביתה וחק לנערותיה
ובכל מצוה שיעשה האדם יכוין
כי נשמתו מתתקנת ומאירה
באור מצוה.[i] ובמעשים שאין
בהם ברכה יוכל האדם הנלבב
לקדשם ולפארם בשפע עליון
בפסוקים קדושים מתורה נביאים
וכתובים וכ״ש כשהמעשה בעצמו
הוא מקודש כגון בעסקו בג״ח
וכדומה שכבר המעשה מוכן
וכלי לשרות בו ברכה ולהחזיק
גם הרוח והנשמה כי יעורה עליו
רוח ממרום ויעלה על במתי
עב ונמצא פועל בארץ ובשמים
ובשמי השמים ובזה הארץ תענה
את השמים והשמים יענו את
הארץ ורב טוב לבית ישראל וה׳
יברך את עמו בשלום:[ii]

with the light of the commandment.

For actions that do not require a blessing, a discerning person can sanctify and adorn them with divine abundance through sacred verses from Torah, 85R
Prophets, and Writings—especially when the action itself is inherently sacred, such as when engaging in acts of loving-kindness and the like. Such actions are already prepared as vessels to contain blessing and to sustain both the ruach and neshamah, for a spirit 90R
from on high will be aroused upon him, and he will ascend upon the heights of the clouds.[1] Thus, he operates on earth, in the heavens, and in the highest heavens. Through this, "the earth shall answer the heavens, and the heavens shall answer the earth," 95R
bringing abundant goodness to the House of Israel, and "the Lord will bless His people with peace."

פרק ב׳

הלא מראש בב׳ חלקים
הקודמים הודענו ומהם ישמע
האדם ויבין דעת לאשורו כמה
צריך האדם לכוין בהתעסקו
בג״ח וצרכי המת בפרט שדל הוא
ואין ידו משגת לעשות התעוררות
תחתון ע״כ מצווים החיים לגמול

Chapter 2

We have already informed in the two previous sections, and from them a person will hear and understand correctly how much one needs to focus their intention when engaging in acts of kindness and the needs of the deceased. Particularly since 5R
the deceased is helpless and unable to create the awakening from below,[A] the living are commanded

[A] Or: "the deceased is impoverished and lacks the means to create the lower awakening" — The term 'dal' literally means 'poor/impoverished' and 'ein yado maseget' literally means 'his hand cannot reach/afford.' This is metaphorical language in the context, referring to the deceased's inability to perform spiritual actions, but a more literal translation might be preferred in some contexts to preserve the economic metaphor in the original Hebrew.

[1] This poetic phrase uses biblical imagery (Isaiah 14:14) to describe spiritual elevation achieved through proper performance of commandments.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of tikkun (rectification), where human actions repair and illuminate both the individual soul and the cosmic order.

[ii] Cf. Pardes Rimmonim by Rabbi Moses Cordovero — The author cites Cordovero's kabbalistic teachings about how physical actions connect to spiritual realms, which forms the theoretical foundation for the entire passage. | Cf. Four Worlds of Kabbalah (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) — The author uses the classic kabbalistic framework of the four worlds to explain how different types of human activity operate on corresponding cosmic levels. | Cf. Proverbs 13:25 — This biblical verse is used to contrast the spiritual approach to physical actions (like eating) with the purely material approach. | Cf. Proverbs 3:6 — This verse is cited to support the author's central argument that even mundane physical activities can be sanctified through proper intention and awareness of God. | Cf. Proverbs 31:15 — The author applies this verse metaphorically to Malkhut (the Divine Presence), portraying it as the feminine divine attribute that distributes spiritual sustenance to lower realms. | Cf. Hosea 2:23-24 — This prophetic verse is used to describe the reciprocal relationship between higher and lower worlds that is established through properly performed commandments. | Cf. Psalms 29:11 — This concluding quote frames the entire teaching as leading to divine blessing and cosmic harmony when properly applied.

חסד לגופו ולנשמתו במעשיהם
ובכוונתם למען בעת במרום
תמריא ותשכון סלע ותתלונן
ברום חביון בכח. ואל חביריו
העומדים עליו להכין אותו
ולסעדו באמת ובמשפט ובצדקה
הלא הוא מעשה ודבור ומחשבה
ראשונה כל אחד מהעומדים
על החולה בשעת יציאת נשמתו
יסובבנהו יבוננהו כדדרשו בזהר
פ׳ האזינו כאשר הודעלו למעלה
למבקרים אותו בתחלת החולי
ויצרנהו כבבת עין העליונה בכח
הבל הקדוש המעלה מפיו סביב
למטתו בסדרי הפסוקים אשר
יבואו לפנינו עד כי יעבור זעם
מעליו ובזה ירחיקו בכל האפשר
הדינים החצונים המלפתים
אותו וסובבים מטתו[i] כי סביב
רשעים יתהלכון. ובזה יאחז
צדיק דרכו והנפש תשוב אל
האלהים אשר נתנה דרך האויר
ההוא המעוטר בשיח רנה ותפלה
ותעלה ותראה עם להקות נפשות
חסידיו אשר באו ללותו ולכבדו
ושכינת אל בראשם עם המלאכי
שלום[ii] ובכבודה תזכה נפשו
לאור באור החיים כי באור
פני מלך חיים אשרי מי שזוכה.
וכל המתעסקים בו בגופו
הן בשמירתו וכ״ש ברחיצתו
ובהלבשתו ובהכנסתו בארגז וכן

to bestow kindness upon both their body and soul through actions and intentions. This is so that when the soul soars upward, it may dwell in the rock and 10R
abide in the heights of concealment through this power.[A]

As for the companions who stand by the deceased to prepare and assist them in truth, justice, and righteousness—this involves action, speech, and 15R
thought. First, each person standing by the sick person at the time of their soul's departure should surround them and watch over them, as expounded in the Zohar, Parashat Ha'azinu, as we have already informed those who visit the sick at the beginning 20R
of illness. They should guard them like the pupil of the supernal eye through the power of the sacred breath that rises from their mouth[1] around the bed, through the arrangement of verses that will come before us, until the wrath passes from them. In 25R
this way, they will distance as much as possible the external judgments that envelop the dying person and surround their bed, for "the wicked walk on every side."[B]

Through this, the righteous person will hold 30R
firmly to their path, and the soul will return to God who gave it, through that air adorned with joyous speech and prayer. It will ascend and appear with the assemblies of the souls of His pious ones who have come to accompany and honor the deceased, 35R
with the Divine Presence at their head together with the angels of peace. Through His glory, the soul will merit to be illuminated in the light of life, for "in the light of the King's countenance is life"—fortunate is

[A] Or: "and lodge in the exalted hidden realm through this power" — The verb 'titlonen' comes from the root for lodging/dwelling temporarily, and 'rom chevyon' refers to the highest hidden realm in kabbalistic thought. This alternate translation might better convey the specific mystical concept of the soul finding temporary lodging in the highest hidden spiritual realms.

[B] Or: "for "the wicked prowl all around"" — This is a quotation from Psalms 12:9, and different English Bible translations render it differently. The alternate translation may better capture the predatory, threatening nature of these external forces of judgment that the text describes as surrounding the dying person.

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that sacred words and prayers create a spiritually purified atmosphere around the dying person. The 'breath' or 'vapor' (hevel) from reciting holy texts is believed to manifest as a protective spiritual force.

[i] The text describes negative spiritual forces called 'external judgments' (dinim chitzonim) that surround the dying person. In kabbalistic thought, these are harmful entities attracted by the judgment aspect of death that attempt to impede the soul's peaceful transition.

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic concept that when a person dies properly, the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) itself comes with angels of peace to escort the soul. This imagery contrasts with the negative spiritual forces mentioned earlier.

נושאי המטה וחלופיהם וחלופי
חלופיהם וכל שלמטה צורך
בהם והבאים ללוותו וא״צ לומר
בעת אומרם צדוק הדין יכוונו
למתק דין הקדוש בכל בחינותיו
בנזכר ולהפריש ולבלע דין
החיצון לשקעו ולגלגלו בנוקבא
דתהומא רבה[i] ובזה יסבר פיו
בעדשה מגולגלת ואדומה ואין
לה פה או לרמז ביצה בנזכר
וכן בנשוא אותו מאיבולא
לסברא בשעת הקבורה יכוונו
בכל מעשיהם לעורר בחות
העליונים כאלו היו כלם בג״ע
לפני השכינה. וכל מגמת פניהם
תהיה לעשות חסד של אמת
עם נפש הנפטר כדוגמא שהם
עושים למטה לצרכי גופו שגם
לנשמה וחלקיה יש להם רמ״א
אברים ושס״ה גידים ועורקים
רוחניים[ii] כמו שיש לגוף כי הוא
דוגמא אליהם בכל מכל כל אלא
שהוא חומרי והם רוחניים וכבר
אמרנו כי פעולות הגשמיות
תפעול ברוחניות וכ״ש כשיש
הדמות בין הגשמי והרוחני
בכל צדדיו הגוף המת עם נפשו
והנלוים עמו וכבר אמרנו שבזמן
הקבורה יש עם הגוף נפשו רוחו
ונשמתו של הנפטר. והכנת
התכריכין כבר אמרנו טעם
למה מוטל על הנשים להיות
תקונם הראשון בעלמא דנוקבא
ויזכוהו בפרוטות צדקה שתתן

one who merits this. 40R

All who attend to the body, whether in guarding it and especially in washing it, dressing it, and placing it in the coffin, as well as those who carry the bier and their replacements, and the replacements of the replacements, and all those needed below, and those who come to accompany it—needless to say when reciting the Justification of Judgment—should intend to sweeten the holy judgment in all its aspects as mentioned, and to separate and swallow the external judgment, sinking it and rolling it into the great abyss.[A] In this way, its mouth will be sealed like a round, red lentil that has no mouth, or to allude to an egg[1] as mentioned. Likewise, when carrying it from mourning to burial at the time of interment, they should direct all their actions to awaken the supernal powers as if they were all in the Garden of Eden before the Divine Presence. 45R 50R 55R

Their entire focus should be to perform true kindness with the soul of the departed, just as they do below for the needs of the body. For the soul and its parts also have 248 spiritual limbs and 365 spiritual sinews and veins, just as the body has, since it is a model for them in every way, except that the body is material while they are spiritual. We have already said that physical actions affect the spiritual realm, especially when there is similarity between the physical and spiritual in all aspects—the dead body with its soul and those accompanying it. We have already said that at the time of burial, the departed one's soul, spirit, and higher soul are with the body. 60R 65R 70R

Regarding the preparation of shrouds, we have already explained why it is the women's responsibility to make the initial preparation in the feminine

[A] Or: "into the opening of the great deep" — The Aramaic term 'nukba d'tehoma raba' is a technical kabbalistic term referring to a specific metaphysical location where negative forces are contained. A more literal translation preserves the gendered imagery in the original (nukba = female/opening) and the reference to Genesis 7:11 (tehom = deep).

[1] These are symbolic references to foods traditionally served to mourners. The round shape represents the cycle of life and death, while the absence of a 'mouth' (opening) represents the silencing of accusatory spiritual forces.

[i] The 'nukba d'tehoma raba' (opening of the great deep) is a kabbalistic concept referring to the metaphysical location where negative forces are contained and neutralized. The proper funeral rituals are understood to direct these harmful forces away from the deceased's soul and into this containment realm.

[ii] The numbers 248 and 365 correspond to the traditional count of positive commandments (248) and negative commandments (365) in Jewish law, totaling 613. This creates a correspondence between the body's structure, the soul's structure, and the Torah's structure.

כל אחת מהן עבור נופר נפשו
בעודן שם וכמו כן האנשים בבית
הקברות ישימו בקופות כל אחד
כפי השגת ידו להרבות צדקה
וחסד לפדיון נפש הנפטר הצריך
לרחמים וטוב לתת לפחות שש
פרוטות למתק הששׁ קצוות
ולביסום שש מדות שיש בהם
דין. ולא לחנם הרגילו בארץ
הצבי לאנשים רשומים ליתן על
גופם זהב וכסף ונחשת כנגד
שלשת חלקי נשמת הנפטר נשמה
מבריאה ששם בחינת הזהב טוב
ורוח מיצירה ששם הכסף ועלמין
דכסופא לרוח ונפש מעשיה ששם
בחינת הנחשת[i] בסוד הרי נחשת
ואח״כ חולקים הכל לעניים כמו
שיבא. ויאמר בכל פרוטה הריני
נותן פרוטה זו לצדקה על כל
ישראל ועל פלוני זה הנפטר
למנוחת נפשו בג״ע ויאמר כל
כלי יוצר עליך לא יצלח וגו׳
וכן בכל פרוטה ופרוטה. גם
ברחיצה הגדולה יש להם סדר
נפלא וסודות מכוונים אשרי
הזוכה להיות נמנה עמהם:[ii]

realm. They merit the deceased through coins of charity[A] that each woman gives for the atonement of his soul while they are there. Similarly, the men at the cemetery should place in charity boxes according to their means, to increase charity and kindness for the redemption of the departed soul that needs mercy. It is good to give at least six coins to sweeten the six extremities and to sweeten the six attributes[1] that contain judgment.

It was not for nothing that it became customary in the Holy Land for distinguished people to place gold, silver, and copper on their bodies, corresponding to the three parts of the departed's soul: the neshamah from the World of Creation, where there is the aspect of good gold; the ruach from the World of Formation, where there is silver and the worlds of longing for the spirit; and the nefesh from the World of Action, where there is the aspect of copper in the mystery of "behold copper." Afterward, they distribute everything to the poor as will be explained. One should say with each coin: "I hereby give this coin for charity for all Israel and for this departed one, for the repose of his soul in the Garden of Eden," and say "No weapon formed against you shall prosper, etc." And so with each and every coin. Also in the great washing there is a wonderful order and directed mysteries[2]—fortunate is one who merits to be counted among them.

[A] Or: "perutot of charity" — The term 'perutah' (plural: perutot) refers to a specific small denomination coin in Jewish law, with precise halakhic significance. Keeping the Hebrew term might be preferred in contexts where the legal or ritual specificity is important.

[1] The 'six extremities' refers to the six directional sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah: Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netzach, Hod, and Yesod. The text suggests that charitable giving in multiples of six helps to transform the judgment aspects of these divine attributes into mercy.

[2] The 'great washing' (rechitzah gedolah) refers to the ritual purification of the deceased's body

[i] This passage describes the correspondence between metals and spiritual worlds: gold with Beriah (Creation), silver with Yetzirah (Formation), and copper with Asiyah (Action). This follows kabbalistic teachings about the decreasing spiritual purity as one descends through the four worlds from Atzilut (Emanation, not mentioned here) to Asiyah.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Ha'azinu — The text cites this Zohar passage as authoritative basis for the protective practices described, establishing continuity between the kabbalistic tradition and the author's instructions for deathbed rituals. | Cf. Psalms 12:9 — The author employs this biblical verse to characterize the external judgments (dinim chitzonim) that surround the deathbed, implying that these forces are the 'wicked' referenced in the psalm. | Cf. Proverbs 16:15 — The author employs this biblical reference to contrast the spiritual darkness of death with the divine light that awaits the properly prepared soul, highlighting the ultimate reward for correct deathbed practices. | Cf. Isaiah 54:17 — The author prescribes this verse as a specific protective recitation that accompanies the giving of charity, intended to shield the deceased's soul from negative spiritual forces during its journey. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The author draws on this kabbalistic concept to explain why physical actions performed for the body have corresponding effects on the soul, establishing the metaphysical basis for funeral rituals.

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

הן מקדם הודעתי למישרי דרך בתורה כוונת העומד בשעת יציאת נשמה. גם שאר העם הנמצאים שם יהיו כלם לאחדים ויכוונו להעלות נפשו קרבן לה׳[i] ליחדא קב״ה עם שכינתיה[ii] ולאתערא כ״י דכד סלקא נשמתא איהי מתאחדת בתיאובתא שלימתא ואתקשר עלמא דנוקבא עם עלמא דדכורא דכלל גדול הוא כי בכל מעשי האדם בעי לכוונא לאכללא מדת יום בלילה ומדת לילה ביום[iii] כנראה בפ׳ קרח דף קע״ז ע״ב על פסוק ראה חיים עם אשה אשר אהבת ובעי בר נש בכל עובדוהי לאכללא שמאלא בימינא בשמא דקב״ה. וכתוב בתקונים דף קל״א ע״א סוף סוף כל מה דאשתדל בר נש בפקודוי דקב״ה בגיניה ובגין שכינתיה הכי אשתדל קב״ה בגין בר נש ובין זוגיה בההוא עלמא זכאה מאן דאשתדל למעבד רעותיה דלית פומא יכול למימר אגרא דיליה בההוא עלמא דאיהו

I have previously informed those who walk the path of Torah about the proper intention for one standing at the moment when a soul departs. The others present should also unite as one and focus their intention on elevating the deceased's soul as an offering to the Lord, unifying the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presenc[1]e, and arousing the Community of Israel. For when a soul ascends, it unites with complete desire, and the feminine realm connects with the masculine realm.[2] It is a fundamental principle that in all human actions, one should intend to include the attribute of day within night and the attribute of night within day,[A] as explained in Parashat Korach, page 177b, on the verse "See life with the woman whom you love." A person should, in all his deeds, include the left within the right in the name of the Holy One, blessed be He.

It is written in Tikkunim, page 131a: "Ultimately, all that a person strives to do in fulfilling the commandments of the Holy One, blessed be He, for His sake and for the sake of His Divine Presence, so does the Holy One, blessed be He, strive for the sake of that person and his spouse in that world. Fortunate is one who strives to do His will, for no mouth can express his reward in that world, which

[A] Or: "For in all human deeds, one must intend to integrate the quality of day into night and the quality of night into day" — This alternate translation uses more active verbs ('integrate' instead of 'include') and 'quality' instead of 'attribute,' which might better convey the dynamic process described. Both translations accurately capture the kabbalistic concept of unifying opposing cosmic forces.

(tahara) performed by the burial society. The author alludes to kabbalistic meanings and procedures for this ritual that are detailed elsewhere in the text.

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'ליחדא קב״ה עם שכינתיה' is a technical kabbalistic formula that appears frequently in Zoharic literature. It refers to the mystical goal of unifying the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, considered the highest purpose of religious practice.

[2] The terms 'עלמא דנוקבא' (feminine realm) and 'עלמא דדכורא' (masculine realm) are kabbalistic concepts referring to cosmic spiritual domains rather than just gender principles. The feminine realm is associated with receptivity, judgment, and this world, while the masculine realm represents bestowal, mercy, and higher spiritual dimensions.

[i] The mystical concept that a person's death can serve as a sacrificial offering is central to this text. Just as Temple sacrifices created unifications in higher realms, proper deathbed rituals elevate the departing soul as a spiritual offering.

[ii] This phrase refers to the central kabbalistic goal of unifying the masculine aspect of God (Holy One, blessed be He) with the feminine aspect (Divine Presence). This unification is considered the ultimate purpose of religious life and is particularly potent during transition moments like death.

[iii] This refers to the mystical practice of unifying opposites, specifically the attributes associated with day (mercy, masculine) and night (judgment, feminine). The text suggests that properly attending to the dying creates this cosmic harmony.

לדרי דרין. ובר״מ פ׳ כי תצא כתיב אין חסיד אלא המתחסד עם קונו דכל פקודין דעביד למפרק בהו שבינתיה ובהא עביד חסד עם הקב״ה. ועיין בסוף פרשה זו בכמה פנים קושרים ישראל שבינה עמהם ומאין ולאין יזדמן לאדם בעה״ז לעשות נייחא לשבינתא להיות במדרגת הכהן עליון המקריב נשמות לפני קונו אם לא בעת כי יראה חכמים ימותו דאז יבודאי בעי לכוונה ולשואה רעותיה ליחודא דקב״ה ושבינתיה ויתחזק כח המוטל על ערש דוי בפסוקי דרחמי ובפיו ימתיקנו במלין קדישין. ובזה מתדבק באילן החיים. ואמרו כי מלאכא דמותא לאשליט על מאן דאשתדל באורייתא לששה אלא מיתתה על פי ה׳ והיא הנשיקה[i] דהוא דבקותא דנפשא בשבינתא ובעקרא דיליה בגין כך צדיקים אינם מטמאים במיתתן[ii] מכה דתיננן ביום שמת רבי בטלה כהונה כלומר דאעסקו ביה דלא שרא עליה רוח מסאבא. א״כ בהתעורר על הנפטר אילנא דחיי בכח רוחניות הנחתם ונעלם בפסוקי אנ״ך בכוונת

endures for generations upon generations." And in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Ki Tetze, it is written: "There is no truly pious one except he who acts with loving-kindness toward his Creator, for all commandments that he performs to redeem His Divine Presence through them—by this he performs loving-kindness for the Holy One, blessed be He."

Examine the end of this section to see the many ways in which Israel binds the Divine Presence with them. When and where does a person have the opportunity in this world to bring comfort to the Divine Presence and to attain the level of the High Priest who offers souls before his Creator? Is it not when he sees that the wise die? Then he should certainly focus his intention and direct his will toward the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence, and strengthen the one lying on the sickbed with verses of mercy, sweetening them with his mouth through holy words. Through this, he becomes attached to the Tree of Life.

They said that the Angel of Death has no dominion over one who engages in Torah for its own sake; rather, his death is "by the mouth of the Lord," which is the "kiss of death"[A]—the cleaving of the soul to the Divine Presence[1] and to its root. For this reason, the righteous do not impart ritual impurity in their death,[2] as we learned: "On the day Rabbi [Judah the Prince] died, the laws of priesthood were suspended," meaning they attended to him because no spirit of impurity rested upon

[A] Or: "They said that the Angel of Death does not rule over one who exerts himself in Torah for its own sake; instead, his death comes through the divine decree, which is the "death by divine kiss"" — This alternate renders 'לששה' as 'for its own sake' more explicitly and translates 'על פי ה" as 'divine decree' rather than the more literal 'by the mouth of the Lord.' The phrase 'death by divine kiss' might better convey this technical kabbalistic concept than 'kiss of death,' which has different connotations in English.

[1] The phrase 'דבקותא דנפשא בשבינתא' describes the soul's mystical union with the Divine Presence at death. This represents the culmination of the spiritual life—the soul returning to its divine source in a state of perfect attachment.

[2] This controversial statement challenges normative Jewish law, which holds that all human corpses convey ritual impurity. The author uses the story of Rabbi Judah the Prince's death to support this mystical concept that the perfectly righteous transcend normal rules of ritual impurity.

[i] The concept of 'death by divine kiss' (mitat neshikah) refers to the most elevated form of death, reserved for the righteous. It is described as a painless, gentle separation of soul from body through direct divine contact, contrasted with the typical death through the Angel of Death.

[ii] This striking statement challenges the normal halakhic assumption that all human corpses convey ritual impurity. The text claims that the completely righteous don't impart ritual impurity because no 'spirit of impurity' rests on them, using the story of Rabbi Judah the Prince's death as evidence.

אותיות ונקודות וטעמים[i] בזה
ישמרוהו ויחיו נשמתו מרתיחת
כחות הדין המתגברים עליו
וישתתפו נצוצות נשמותם עם
נשמות הצדיקים המתים[ii] הבאים
ללוותו אלו פורשים כנפיהם
עליו מלמעלה והחיים מסייעים
אותו מלמטה ובשתים יכסו פניו
מלמעלה ובשתים יכסו רגליו
מלמטה ובזכותו יעופף להקרב
קרבן לפני ה׳ במזבחו הטהור
ע״י מיכאל כהנה רבה[iii] בעונתה
ובזה יתעורר כהן עליון
שבאצילות חסד אל כל היום על
פי מדותיו ורוח אחד יחיה להם
באחדותא בדבקותא וברעותא
שלים ינהרון כל בוצינין עילאין
ויתרק עליהון משחא דרבותא
עילא עילאה מעתיקא קדישא
סתימא דכלא. ואמרו בפ׳
ויחי דף רמ״ח ת״ח כד נשמתא
סלקא אתער כלא לגבי נוקבא

him.

Therefore, by awakening the Tree of Life over the departed through the power of spirituality sealed and hidden in the verses of Scripture[A]—with the intention directed to their letters, vowels, and cantillation marks—they will protect him and revive his soul from the intensity of the forces of judgment prevailing over him.[B] The sparks of their souls will join with the souls of the righteous dead who come to accompany him. These spread their wings over him from above, while the living assist him from below. "With two they cover his face from above, and with two they cover his feet from below."[1] Through this merit, he will fly to be offered as a sacrifice before the Lord on His pure altar by Michael, the great priest, in his appointed time.

This will arouse the supernal priest in the realm of Emanation—Chesed,[2] Divine loving-kindness—throughout the day according to his attributes. One spirit will enliven them in unity, attachment, and complete will.[C] All the supernal lights will shine, and the supreme anointing oil will be poured

[A] Or: "when arousing the Tree of Life over the deceased through the spiritual power embedded and concealed within biblical verses" — This alternate version uses 'arousing' instead of 'awakening' for 'בהתעורר' and 'embedded' instead of 'sealed,' which might better convey the mystical concept that divine power is inherently contained within the text rather than merely sealed within it. The term 'biblical verses' is more specific than the general 'verses of Scripture.'

[B] Or: "they will safeguard him and vitalize his soul from the fervor of the powers of judgment that intensify against him" — This alternative uses 'safeguard' and 'vitalize' which might better capture the active, energetic nature of the spiritual protection described. 'Fervor' for 'רתיחת' (literally 'boiling/seething') and 'intensify' for 'המתגברים' (from root meaning 'to strengthen/overpower') may better convey the dynamic, threatening quality of these judgment forces.

[C] Or: "A single spirit will animate them in unification, cleaving, and perfect desire" — This alternative uses more technical mystical terminology: 'unification' for 'אחדותא', 'cleaving' for 'דבקותא' (which has specific connotations in Jewish mysticism of spiritual adhesion), and 'perfect desire' for 'רעותא שלים' (which better captures the willful yearning implied in the Aramaic term). 'Animate' may also better convey the life-giving quality implied in 'יחיה'.

[1] This is an allusion to Isaiah 6:2, which describes seraphic angels covering their faces and feet with their wings in the divine presence. By applying this imagery to the dying person, the text suggests they are being treated with the same reverence as the divine presence itself.

[2] This refers to the divine attribute of Loving-kindness (Chesed) in the highest spiritual world (Atzilut/Emanation). In kabbalistic cosmology, human actions on earth activate corresponding forces in these upper spiritual realms.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that Hebrew letters, vowels, and cantillation marks contain divine power that can be activated through proper intention. The text suggests that biblical verses recited with this awareness create tangible spiritual protection for the dying person.

[ii] This describes a mystical cooperation between the souls of the living attendants and the souls of deceased righteous individuals who come to escort the departing soul. This creates a supernatural protection both from above (dead souls) and below (living attendants).

[iii] The archangel Michael is depicted as a celestial High Priest who receives the soul as an offering. This creates a parallel between earthly death rituals and the Temple service, with Michael serving the same function as the High Priest did in the Jerusalem Temple.

דהא איהי אתאחדת בתיאובתא
80 שלימתא ואתקשרת ביה ואם
ימצאו שם עשרה שיעסקו כלם
בדברים שבקדושה[i] ובשירי
דוד שכינה הבוחרת בשירי
זמרה אתיא על ראש המטה
85 עם עלמות שיר ומלאכין
דשכינתא דצלותא דסגיאין
קב״ה מתעטר בה בגין דסלקא
בגווניו סגיאין ואתכלילת מכמה
סטרין ואתעבידא עטרה ומנחא
90 ע״י סנדלפון רבא ויקירא על
רישא דצדיק חי עלמא:[ii]

upon them from the Holy Ancient One, the most concealed of all.[1] 80R

And they said in Parashat Vayechi, page 248: "Come and see, when the soul ascends, everything is aroused toward the feminine aspect, for it unites with complete desire and attaches itself to it." And if ten people are found there who engage in matters 85R of holiness and in the songs of David, the Divine Presence, who chooses melodious songs, comes to the head of the bed with maidens of song and the angels of the Divine Presence. For when many pray, the Holy One, blessed be He, is crowned with their 90R prayer because it ascends with many aspects and includes many sides, and becomes a crown placed by the great and precious Sandalphon on the head of the Righteous One, the Life of the World.[2]

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

מה נאמר ומה נדבר ומה נצטדק
בראותינו גם בני אדם גם בני
איש כי הבל יחמיון ומלתי מילין
הציקתני רוחי בטני בראותי

What can we say, what can we speak, and how can we justify ourselves[3] when we see both ordinary people and distinguished individuals[4] murmuring vanity? Words press upon me, my spirit and my

[1] This refers to 'עתיקא קדישא' (Atika Kadisha), one of the highest divine configurations in Kabbalah, representing God's most hidden essence. The text suggests that proper deathbed ritual can draw down illumination from even this most elevated source.

[2] The angel Sandalphon is described here in his role of weaving crowns from prayers and placing them on the divine head. 'Righteous One, Life of the World' (צדיק חי עלמא) refers to a divine configuration, specifically the sefirah of Yesod, which channels divine flow into our world.

[3] The opening follows a classic rhetorical structure in Jewish ethical literature, using a series of rhetorical questions to express deep dismay at human behavior.

[4] The Hebrew 'בני אדם' and 'בני איש' creates a distinction between common people and those of higher status, emphasizing that this problem affects all social classes.

[i] This emphasizes the importance of having a minyan (quorum of ten) present at death, not just for prayers but for creating a sacred space where the Divine Presence manifests. When ten people focus on holy matters at the deathbed, they create a conduit for divine energies.

[ii] Cf. Parashat Korach, Zohar 177b — This passage is cited to establish the kabbalistic principle that all religious actions should unify opposing divine forces, particularly masculine and feminine aspects. This foundational concept explains why proper care for the dying is spiritually powerful—it unites divine realms. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 131a — This reference establishes that divine reward matches human effort—just as humans strive to unify divine aspects through commandments, God provides corresponding spiritual benefits to humans and their partners in the afterlife. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Ki Tetze — This citation explains that proper deathbed rituals constitute 'loving-kindness toward God' by helping to 'redeem' the Divine Presence. This positions care for the dying as a supreme religious duty that directly benefits both the divine and human realms. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi 248 — This reference explains that a soul's departure creates cosmic reverberations, specifically arousing the feminine aspect of divinity. It suggests that death is not merely a human event but a cosmic one that affects higher spiritual realms. | Cf. Isaiah 6:2 — The phrase 'With two they cover his face from above, and with two they cover his feet from below' alludes to Isaiah's throne vision, suggesting that the dying person is being treated with the same reverence as the divine presence itself, with attending souls acting like the seraphim in Isaiah's vision.

המתאספים בבית הגוסס. וכן מדי עסקם בגופו אחר מותו ומספרים שיחות בטלות ודברים הרבה מרבים הבל שיש בו חטא ואוכלין ושותין ופוחזין כדאמרי׳ בירו׳ מסכת מ״ק כי אין לשעות בדברי שקר רק לעשות מלאכתן מלאכת שמים והרבה ריקים ופוחזים שפיהם שם עביט של מי רגלים[i] ומנבלים פיהם בבית המת ובבתי הקברות ובזה מרחיקים הקדושה מהם ומהמונם ובדד ישבו כי הם נזופים לשמים וקיימי ארבעים יום דלא אשתמע צלותהון ולא עיילא לפרגודא.[ii] והרבה סוררים נשבעים שבועת שוא ושקר ומתלוצצים שם ובזה מעוררים כח הגיהנם ח״ו ובפרט בליצנות מחזיקים מוסרות הדין כדאמרי׳ בפ״ק דע״ג קשה ליצנות שתחלתו יסורין וסופו כליה שנאמר ועתה אל תתלוצצו וגו׳. ופעמים מריבין ומחרפין ומגדפין זה את זה ומכים זה לזה. ובזה מסתירים כח הרחמים והדין הווה באויר המלא שוא ודבר כזב ואין בהם משכיל אל דל המוטל לפניהם נמצא

innermost being are troubled[A] when I observe those who gather in the house of a dying person. Similarly, while they attend to the body after death, they engage in idle talk and multiply meaningless words that contain sin. They eat, drink, and act frivolously, as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud, tractate Mo'ed Katan, for one should not waste time with falsehoods but rather perform their task—the work of Heaven. Many empty and frivolous people make their mouths like a vessel of waste and defile their speech in the house of the deceased and in cemeteries, thereby distancing holiness from themselves and their crowd.[B] They dwell alone because they are under divine censure,[1] and for forty days their prayers are not heard and do not pass through the heavenly curtain. Many rebellious ones swear false and vain oaths and mock there, thus arousing the power of Gehenna, God forbid. Especially through mockery, they strengthen the bonds of judgment, as stated in the first chapter of Avodah Zarah: "Mockery is severe, for its beginning is suffering and its end is destruction, as it is said, 'Now do not scoff, etc.'" Sometimes they quarrel, insult, and revile one another, even striking each other. In this way, they conceal the power of mercy, and judgment hovers in the air filled with falsehood and lies. None of them considers the poor soul laid before them[C]—thus the defender becomes a prosecutor and sin extinguishes a mitzvah. Many

[A] Or: "Words burden me, and my spirit in my belly causes me anguish" — This alternative translation is more literal and preserves the somatic dimension of the spiritual distress, which is characteristic of biblical Hebrew expressions of emotional turmoil where the belly/innards are the seat of emotions. This might be preferred in contexts seeking to emphasize the physical manifestation of spiritual distress.

[B] Or: "through this they cause holiness to withdraw from themselves and their assembly" — This alternative emphasizes the active agency of the inappropriate behavior in causing the withdrawal of divine presence, rather than merely creating distance. It might be preferred in contexts emphasizing human responsibility for spiritual consequences.

[C] Or: "None among them pays wise attention to the vulnerable one lying before them" — This alternative preserves the allusion to Psalm 41:1 ('Happy is he who considers the poor/vulnerable') and emphasizes the wisdom aspect of 'משכיל'. It might be preferred in contexts where the biblical resonance is important.

[1] The phrase 'נזופים לשמים' refers to being in a state of divine disapproval or rebuke, a serious spiritual condition that isolates the person from divine communion.

[i] The author uses a particularly harsh metaphor here comparing the mouths of inappropriate funeral attendees to a vessel for waste water, emphasizing the severity of inappropriate speech in the presence of the dead.

[ii] This references the rabbinic concept that certain improper behaviors result in a forty-day period during which one's prayers cannot ascend through the heavenly curtain (pargod) to be heard by God.

הסניגור נעשה קטיגור ועבירה
מכבה מצוה. וכמה פעמים
צווחתי בכרוכיא ונתתי עליהם
בקולי לבל יאשמו בזה. וכל
שאפשר בידו למחות בהם ומוחה
עושה חסד עם החיים ועם המתים
וזכות הרבים תלוי בו והמצוה
הזאת על הכהנים והשרים אשר
בכל עיר ועיר להחזיק בדק
זה. ולהרים מכשול מדרך עמי
אני אהרן ברכיה ממודינ״ה
יצ״ו[i] הצעיר שבמשפחתי בינותי
במקרא ושום שכל במזמורים
ופסוקים מסוגלים בסדרם
ובטעמם[ii] כל אחד קורא זה לזה
בכוונה נאותה אפי׳ כפי פשטם
מלבד שהמעמיק בהם ימצא נופת
מתוק בסדר קריאתן והצעתי
אותם לפני בני גילי הצריכים
סעד לתומכם אשר על שפתם
יכונו קצת מהם או כלם מדי
עסקם בגמילות חסד של אמת וכן
המזמורים הם מסוגלים לכוונה
זו כפי פשט הפסוקים מלבד
כוונה מסותרת שיש בכל א׳ מהם
בכלל ובפרט ובראשי תיבות
ובסופי תיבות ורמז תמורות
של כ״ב אלפא ביתות[iii] קצתם
יכוונו לתקון נפש רוח נשמה
וחלוץ עצמות וכפרת אשמות
וקצת מהם לדפוק על פתחי
רחמים שעל הארץ יריקו וקצת
מהם נגד נפשות הצדיקים המתים
אשר שמה כי באים נגד הצדיק

times I have cried out loudly and raised my voice against them so they would not be guilty of this. Anyone who can protest against them and does so performs kindness for both the living and the dead, and the merit of the many depends on him. This responsibility falls upon the priests and leaders in every city to maintain this breach[1] and to remove stumbling blocks from the path of my people.

I, Aaron Berechia of Modena (may his Rock preserve him and grant him life), the youngest in my family, have contemplated Scripture and applied my understanding to psalms and verses that are spiritually potent in their arrangement and meaning. Each calls to the other with proper intention,[2] even according to their plain meaning, though one who delves deeper will find sweet honey in the order of their recitation. I have presented these before my contemporaries who need support, that some or all of these may be established upon their lips as they engage in true acts of loving-kindness. These psalms are suited for this purpose according to the plain meaning of the verses, besides the hidden intentions contained in each of them—generally and specifically, in their initial and final letters, and in the encoded transformations of the twenty-two letters of the alphabet. Some are intended for rectifying the soul, spirit, and higher soul,[3] for strengthening the bones, and for atonement of guilt. Some are for knocking on the gates of mercy to pour forth upon the earth, and some correspond to the souls of the righteous dead who are present, for they come to support the righteous one from among those righteous who performed similar deeds, besides his relatives and those who have mercy on him. This is clearly evident from

[1] The Hebrew ‘להחזיק בדק’ refers to maintaining or repairing breaches, a metaphor drawn from Temple maintenance that the author applies to maintaining proper spiritual conduct.

[2] This appears to allude to Isaiah 6:3 where the seraphim call to one another ‘Holy, Holy, Holy,’ suggesting that the properly arranged biblical verses create a celestial harmony similar to angelic praise.

[3] The Hebrew terms ‘נפש רוח נשמה’ refer to the three primary levels of the soul in Kabbalah, which require different types of spiritual rectification.

[i] The author identifies himself here as Aaron Berechia of Modena. The acronym יצ״ו stands for ‘ישמרהו צורו ויחייהו’ (may his Rock preserve him and grant him life).

[ii] The author indicates that he has carefully arranged psalms and biblical verses in specific sequences that have spiritual potency (segulah) not just in their content but in their order and cantillation, reflecting kabbalistic principles about the spiritual power of proper textual arrangements.

[iii] This refers to various kabbalistic techniques for interpreting and activating the mystical power of sacred texts, including notarikon (acronyms formed from initial or final letters) and temurah (letter substitution using the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet).

מאותן הצדיקים שעשו מעין מעשיו[i] מלבד קריבוי ורחמוהי
70 וזה נראה ברור מכמה מעשים שהובאו בירו׳ פ׳ אחרון דסוטה. ומהם לבסום כחות הדין ומהם ליחוד קב״ה ושכינתיה ומהם להגין מהחצונים בפסוקי היחוד
75 כחות קדושים מקבלים עם כחות משפיעים. מקבלים דין מן דין ביחוד קרבנא דא דסליק כדפי׳ בפ׳ נח דף ס״ח דאמרו בר נש דאיהו זכאה איהו קרבנא ממש
80 לכפרא ויחד כלם עונין ואומרים קדוש קדוש קדוש ה׳ צבאות מלא כל הארץ כבודו. ועיין בר״מ פ׳ בהר סיני דף ק״ט דפי׳ סוד כחות קדושים משפיעים
85 וכחות מקבלים בדרוש שאומר כי התפלות מיחדות מדרגות האצילות המתלבש בשבת בהיכלות הבריאה ובחול על לבושי מלכות אלו יש לבושי חול
90 כי הבריאה מתלבשת בז׳ היכלות היצירה. ברם התקרבות כורסיין ומלאכי דאינון אברים מלבד צריך הקרבות ונפש ורוח הצדיק ודאי בעלייתה היא קרבן לקרב
95 גופין ואברין דלבר ממלכא ומטרוניתא. ובכח עליית נשמתו עם הגה הקדוש המעלים החיים עליו יעשה קרוב ויחוד באורות עולם האצילות בפנימיותם ששם
100 עולה הבל התפלה והתחנה עם סוד המחשבה שהיא בעולם הכל. ומשם היא מקור הנשמה. וכבר ידענו כי מההבלי העולים מפסוקי התורה נעשה מכל אות
105 ואות מלאך רוחני המתעלה

several accounts brought in the Jerusalem Talmud in the final chapter of Sotah.

Some verses serve to sweeten the forces of judgment, some for unifying the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence, and some to protect against external forces. In verses of unification, holy forces that receive join with forces that bestow.[A] They receive judgment from judgment in unity, this offering that ascends, as explained in Parashat Noach, page 68, where they stated that a person who is meritorious is literally an offering for atonement. Together they all respond and say: "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of His glory." See also Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Behar Sinai, page 109, which explains the secret of holy forces that bestow and forces that receive, in the discourse stating that prayers unify the levels of Atzilut (Emanation) which clothe themselves on Sabbath in the palaces of Beriah (Creation), and on weekdays in the garments of Malkhut (Kingdom). These are weekday garments, for Beriah clothes itself in the seven palaces of Yetzirah[1] (Formation).

However, the approach of the Thrones and angels, which are limbs, requires additional offerings. And certainly the soul and spirit of the righteous person, in their ascent, are an offering to bring near the bodies and limbs that are outside the King and Queen. Through the power of the ascent of his soul, along with the holy utterance that the living raise over him, a drawing near and unification occurs in the inner lights of the world of Atzilut, where the breath of prayer and supplication ascends, along with the secret of thought which is in the world of the All. From there is the source of the soul.

We already know that from the breaths rising from verses of the Torah, from each and every letter, a spiritual angel is formed that ascends level

70R 75R 80R 85R 90R 95R 100R 105R

[A] Or: "receptive holy powers unite with emanating powers" — This alternative translation uses 'powers' instead of 'forces' and more directly indicates the kabbalistic principle of masculine/feminine or giving/receiving energies in the divine realm. This might be preferred in contexts emphasizing technical kabbalistic terminology.

[1] In Kabbalistic cosmology, each spiritual world (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah) contains internal structures including palaces (heichalot) that serve as dwelling places for different spiritual entities and forces.

[i] This presents the important kabbalistic concept that righteous souls who performed similar deeds during their lifetimes come to assist the newly departed soul in its transition, creating spiritual affinities that transcend death.

מדרגה אחר מדרגה עד שרש
הענין ההוא ויפעלו למעלה
פעולה נפלאת עד כי יתעורר
שפע עליון לירד ולהשפיע דרך
מקומות אחיזת נשמתו שנשאר
שרשם למעלה כי אין דבר
רוחני נעקר ממקומו ומה שנכנס
באדם הוא מהתפשטות שרשה
העליון. ונמצא חוט משוך בין
הנפש לאדם וחוט אחר בין הרוח
לאדם וחוט אחר בין הנשמה
לו[i] והם כשלשה חוטין של שתי
והמצות והמעשים טובים הם
בחוטי ערב[ii] המחזיקים ג׳ חוטי
שתי אלו ועושה אותו יריעה
קיימת בן האדם ע״י תורה ומצות
מוסיף מאורי אור בחינות שרשי
קדושת התורה ומצות בצנור
המשכת קדושת חלקי נפשו והוא
כמוסיף ערב על השתי. והעון
מתדבק בנפש ומפסיק בין צנור
קדושת חלקי נפשו לקונו. וזהו
קפדתי כאורג חיי.[iii] ואין לו
תקון עד ישוב יחבר ההבדל אשר
הבדיל והפסיק בטומאת עונו
ע״י תשובה בעה״ז או ע״י מירוק
חלאת העון אחרי מותו כי עד
אשר ישיב לחבר נפשו עם קונו
א״א לו ליהנות מאושר מעשיו
הטובים[iv] שכל עקר האושר אינו

after level until the root of that matter. They operate above in a wondrous way until they arouse a supernal flow to descend and influence through the places where his soul is anchored, whose roots remain above. For no spiritual thing is uprooted 110R
from its place, and what enters a person is from the extension of its supernal root.[1] Thus, there is a thread stretched between the nefesh and the person, another thread between the ruach and the person, and another thread between the neshamah and him. 115R
These are like three threads of warp, and the commandments and good deeds are like threads of weft that strengthen these three warp threads, making them into an enduring fabric. Similarly, a person, through Torah and commandments, adds illumina- 120R
tions of light to the aspects of the roots of the holiness of Torah and commandments in the channel that draws the holiness of the portions of his soul, like adding weft to warp.

Sin clings to the soul and interrupts between the 125R
channel of holiness of the parts of his soul and his Creator. This is the meaning of "I have been cut off like a weaver's thread."[A] There is no rectification until he returns and reconnects[2] what was separated and interrupted by the impurity of his sin, through 130R
repentance in this world or through the cleansing of the filth of sin after death. For until he returns to connect his soul with his Creator, it is impossible for him to enjoy the happiness of his good deeds, since the essence of happiness is nothing but the attach- 135R

[A] Or: "I have rolled up like a weaver my life" — This alternative follows the Hebrew of Isaiah 38:12 more literally. The image is of a weaver who, having finished a piece of cloth, cuts it from the loom and rolls it up. This might be preferred in contexts where the precise biblical allusion is important.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic principle that all earthly phenomena are extensions or projections of higher spiritual realities, with nothing existing in the lower worlds without a corresponding root in the upper worlds.

[2] This emphasizes the kabbalistic concept of teshuvah (repentance) as literally a 'return' that repairs cosmic connections, not merely a change in behavior.

[i] The author presents the kabbalistic concept that the three main soul components (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) remain connected to their divine source through spiritual threads or channels, creating a continuous connection between the human being and the divine realms.

[ii] This weaving metaphor is central to the author's understanding of spiritual dynamics: the soul components are like vertical warp threads, while commandments and good deeds are like horizontal weft threads that strengthen and connect the structure. This explains why proper ritual actions are essential for the soul's integrity.

[iii] The author quotes from Isaiah 38:12, part of King Hezekiah's prayer when he was critically ill, continuing the weaving metaphor to explain how sin disrupts the spiritual fabric of life.

[iv] This expresses the fundamental kabbalistic principle that the ultimate purpose of human existence

כי אם דבקות נפשו עם קונו ואיך יהיה לו כן והוא נפרד ממנו וגם כל מעשה הטוב אשר יעשה האדם לא יהנה ממנו אחרי מותו עד ירחץ יטהר מטומאתו כמשל האורג הקוצר יריעתו כמדובר. וכן אם יתפלל לא יעלה הבל פיו לרצון עד אחר תשובתו כי אח״כ יחזרו וישפיעו דרך מדרגות אחיזת נשמתו והכל לפי הכוונה. ואפי׳ פשטי הדברים יעוררו עד מלכות אך הוא כמי שמדבר מאחרי כתפיו וזה מתבאר בפ׳ חקת ועיין בפ׳ ויקהל דף רי״ז כי שם פי׳ איך מעוררים למעלה מלות התפלה והתורה ושירי זמרה: [i]

ment of his soul to its Creator. How can this be so for him when he is separated from Him? Also, all the good deeds that a person performs will not benefit him after death until he washes and purifies himself from his impurity, like the example of the weaver cutting his fabric, as mentioned. Similarly, if he prays, the breath of his mouth will not ascend favorably until after his repentance, for afterward they will return and influence through the levels where his soul is anchored, all according to the intention. Even the plain meanings of the words will arouse up to Malkhut, but it is like one who speaks from behind his shoulders.[1] This is explained in Parashat Chukat, and see Parashat Vayakhel, page 217, for there it explains how the words of prayer, Torah, and songs of praise arouse above.

פרק ה׳

Chapter 5

אלה הם ציוני המזמורים וכל יחיד יבחר מהם מה שיראה בעיניו או יוסיף עליהם מדעתו הרחבה מזמור ט״ז כ׳ כ״ב כ״ג כ״ד כ״ה ל׳ מ״ב מ״ג נ״א ס״ו פ״ד יושב בסתר ק״ג קי״ז קי״ח ק״כ קכ״א קכ״ג ק״ל ק״מ קמ״א קמ״ב קמ״ג קמ״ח קמ״ט ק״נ

These are the designated psalms, and each individual may choose from them as seems appropriate in their eyes, or add to them according to their broad understanding: Psalms 16, 20, 22, 23, 24, 25, 30, 42, 43, 51, 66, 84, “He who dwells in the shelter” [Psalm 91], 103, 117, 118, 120, 121, 123, 130, 140, 141, 142, 143, 148, 149, and 150. And concerning Psalms 148 and 150, it is written in Parashat Pekudei, page 232,

[1] This vivid metaphor suggests that prayer without proper repentance still reaches the divine realm of Malkhut but in an indirect, ineffective manner, as if speaking while facing away from the listener.

is devekut (attachment/cleaving to God), and that sin’s primary damage is the separation it creates between the soul and its divine source.

[i] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Mo’ed Katan — The reference establishes halakhic authority for the author’s criticism of inappropriate behavior during deathbed and funeral rituals | Cf. Tractate Avodah Zarah — The citation provides textual support from rabbinic literature for the author’s admonition against disrespectful behavior in the presence of the dying or deceased | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Sotah — This reference supports the kabbalistic concept that souls of righteous individuals who performed similar deeds in life come to assist the newly departed soul in its transition | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Noach — This reference establishes the kabbalistic foundation for the author’s instruction that the soul of a righteous person serves as a spiritual sacrifice that ascends to higher realms | Cf. Ra’aya Mehemna, Parashat Behar Sinai — This citation provides the mystical framework for understanding how the prayers and meditations offered at deathbed rituals function to unify divine worlds, particularly explaining the difference between Sabbath and weekday spiritual dynamics | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Chukat — This reference expands the reader’s understanding of how spiritual mechanics function when prayers are offered in an impure state, explaining that they still reach Malkhut but with diminished efficacy | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This reference provides detailed kabbalistic teachings about the spiritual dynamics of prayer and Torah recitation, which is central to understanding the efficacy of deathbed rituals proposed in Ma’avar Yabok | Cf. Isaiah 38:12 — This biblical reference connects the text to traditional Jewish deathbed prayers, specifically using the metaphor of weaving to explain how sin disrupts the spiritual fabric connecting soul to Creator

ומזמור קמ״ח וק״נ כתוב בפרשת
פקודי דף רל״ב שהם כלל כל
התושבחות ויחד כלם שם כ״ח
מזמורים כנגד כ״ח פרקים שביד
הגדולה שהוא שם ההוי״ה בד׳
אותיותיו ומלואו[i] שהם י״ד ויד
החזקה הוא שם אהיה ומלואו
המושפע משם הוי״ה שהוא לימין
והוא ג״כ י״ד וליחוד כ״ח מחנות
שכינה שהיא הלבנה העליונה
המלבנת עונותיהם של ישראל
המזדמנת עם מחנות יה להקביל
הנשמה הקדושה העולה ליחדה
ולקשרה עם קוצה. והם מוסיפים
כח ומחלימים ומחיים הנשמה
וגם הגוף. ומיבעי לאדם לארמא
ימינא על שמאלא בכח יד רמה
המתווכת ביניהם שבכחה הוא
גידול שמיה רבה שהם עשר
אותיות של הוי״ה מנוקדים חולם
סגול קמץ סגול. ויבואו אחריהם
קי״ב פסוקי תורה נביאים
וכתובים יחד כלם טובים לישא
אותם על שפתיו האיש הישראלי
מדי אשר הוא מוכן לעבור
המעבר יב״ק[ii] מתחתית לעילית
וימצע ביניהם מהמזמורים
הנרשמים א׳ או ב׳ או ג׳ ומספר
מפקד הפסוקים מכוון ליחוד ג׳
שמות שהם אהי״ה הוי״ה אדנו״ת
מספרם יחד קי״ב. ויכוין האומר
בי נצוץ נשמת החולה שכלולה
בנשמתו על דרך שכל ישראל
ערבין זה לזה בכחה מסייע ונותן
כח ואון לו ופיו כפיו ודבורו

that they encompass all praises. Together, there are
28 psalms, corresponding to the 28 sections of the 10R
"Great Hand" [Yad HaChazakah], which is the di-
vine name YHVH in its four letters and their full
spelling, which equals 14, and the "Strong Hand" is
the divine name Ehyeh and its full spelling, which
flows from the name YHVH, which is on the right, 15R
and it also equals 14. This is for the unification of
the 28 camps of the Divine Presence, which is the
supernal moon that whitens the sins of Israel,[1] and
which joins with the camps of Yah to receive the
holy soul as it ascends, to unify it and bind it with 20R
its Source. These add strength, heal, and enliven
both the soul and the body.[2]

One must elevate the right over the left through
the power of the "uplifted hand" that mediates be-
tween them, through which comes the magnification 25R
of "His great Name," which consists of the ten let-
ters of YHVH vocalized with cholam, segol, kamatz,
segol. Following these come 112 verses from Torah,
Prophets, and Writings, all of which are good for an
Israelite to recite when prepared to cross the YaBOK 30R
passage from the lower to the higher realm. Among
these verses, one should intersperse one, two, or three
of the designated psalms. The number of these verses
is intentionally set at 112, corresponding to the uni-
fication of three divine names: Ehyeh, YHVH, and 35R
Adnut, which together have the numerical value of
112.

The one who recites should have in mind that a
spark of the sick person's soul is included within his
own soul, in the manner that all Israel are guaran- 40R
tors for one another. Through this power, he assists
and gives strength and vigor to the sick person, so
that his mouth becomes like the mouth of the sick

[1] This phrase employs a wordplay in Hebrew between 'levanah' (moon) and 'malbenet' (whitens/purifies), suggesting that the Divine Presence, compared to the moon, has a purifying effect on sins, turning them white (an idiom for forgiveness in Hebrew based on Isaiah 1:18).

[2] The text establishes that proper recitation of these psalms and verses has both spiritual and physical therapeutic effects, representing the holistic approach to healing characteristic of kabbalistic medicine.

[i] The text refers to the divine name YHVH (יהוה) and its 'filling' or 'full spelling' where each letter is spelled out in full. This kabbalistic technique creates expanded forms of divine names with deeper mystical significance.

[ii] The Hebrew term 'YaBOK' (יב״ק) has multiple levels of significance: it refers to the biblical Jabbok river that Jacob crossed (Genesis 32), it has the numerical value of 112 (which equals the combined value of three divine names), and its letters form an acronym for 'He will answer us on the day we call' (יעננו ביום קראנו).

כדבור המוטל על ערש דוי וכמו
שמוסיף שבע רצון על נשמת
האיש הלזה בזה יתוסף לו רבו
וחיי וחינא וחסדא וכל המוסיף
מוסיפין לו. ואמרו כי תיבת אמן
אותיות הבאות אחרי ג׳ אלה
הם בנס ויש אומרים שהוא שם
קדוש והוא בסוד היחוד על ידו.
ושם זה עולה קי״ב וגם יב״ק
שהוא שם קדוש ועליו נאמר
ויעבר את מעבר יב״ק והוא
סוד ״יעננו ״ביום ״קראנו והוא
סוד יחוד ברכה קדושה. יחוד
באמצע בת״ת. קדושה משמאל.
דכתיב וקדשת את הלוים. ברכה
מימין. והם סוד ג׳ שמות הנזכר.
וג׳ שמות אלו הם סוד פסוק
שיר השירים אשר לשלמה וי״ב
אותיות אלו מצורפים יש להם כח
גדול לכל דבר והוא סוד מלכות
ת״ת בינה או כתר שבשתיהם
צודק שם אהי״ה וצרופם אות
א׳ מכל שם. ויש מוסיפין עמו
ג״כ סוד שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו
ה׳ ישראל ה׳ מימין. אלהינו
משמאל. ה׳ שהיא יחוד הכל
יחד באמצע ור״ת ארבע מלות
אלו הוא ייא״י והיינו מלוי שם
ס״ג והוא שם קדוש ולפי זה הם
ד׳ שמות ידו״ד ייא״י אהי״ה
אדנ״י ומהם יצטרפו ד׳ שמות
בנודע. ובספר הקנה הפליא
לדבר בסגולתם ושם הנתוסף על
יב״ק עולה אל והיינו אל יב״ק
והוא שם קדוש והיינו כי במקלי
עברתי כ״י עולה א״ל עם המלה.
במקלי סוף תיבה ואמצע תיבה
וראש תיבה יב״ק ושם ייא״י סודו
בכתר והוא היחוד הגמור והוא
מתלבש בשם אהי״ה ושם ידו״ד
מתלבש באדני. ויש עוד הוי״ה
ואהי״ה בסוד רישא דמלכא
והוי״ה ואדנו״ת בסוד התפשטות

person,[1] and his speech like the speech of the one lying on the sickbed. Just as he adds divine favor to the soul of this person, so will increase come to him—increase of his teacher's wisdom, life, grace, and kindness—for whoever adds, to him it shall be added. 45R

They have said that the word "Amen" consists of letters that follow the letters of these three divine names by the miracle of gematria, and some say it is a holy name involved in the mystery of unification. This name has the numerical value of 112, as does YaBOK, which is a holy name, and concerning it is said, "And he crossed the ford of Yabok" [Genesis 32:23]. This contains the mystery of "He will answer us on the day we call" [the initials of which spell YaBOK], and it is the mystery of Unification, Blessing, and Holiness.[2] Unification is in the middle, in Tiferet; Holiness is on the left, as it is written, "And you shall sanctify the Levites"; Blessing is on the right. These are the secret of the three names mentioned above. 50R 55R 60R

These three names are also the secret of the verse "The Song of Songs, which is Solomon's," and these twelve letters, when combined, have great power for all matters. This is the mystery of Malkhut, Tiferet, and Binah, or Keter, for in both of the latter the name Ehyeh is appropriate, and their combination takes one letter from each name. Some also add the mystery of "Hear, O Israel: the LORD our God, the LORD" [Deuteronomy 6:4]—"Israel" and "the LORD" on the right, "our God" on the left, and "the LORD," which unifies everything, in the middle. The initial letters of these four words spell YeYA"I, which is the filling of the name Sa"G, a holy name. According to this, there are four names: YHVH, YeYA"I, Ehyeh, and Adny, from which are formed four names, as is known. 65R 70R 75R 80R

In the book HaKaneh, there is wonderful discussion of their properties. The name that is added to YaBOK equals E"L, meaning "El YaBOK" is a holy name, as in "for with my staff [bemakli] I crossed" [Genesis 32:11]—"KI" equals E"L with the word. "BeMakli" contains the final letter, middle 85R

[1] This describes a mystical principle of representation or substitution, where the one reciting prayers becomes a spiritual proxy for the sick person, channeling divine energy on their behalf.

[2] These three concepts correspond to the three letters of YaBOK (יב״ק): Yod for Yichud (unification), Bet for Berachah (blessing), and Kuf for Kedushah (holiness), showing how the acronym itself contains the essence of the mystical practice.

גופא והם א׳ אל הימין וא׳
אל השמאל ומתייחדים באמצע
בנזכר בספ״ר ובהם סוד יחוד
מלמעלה למטה וממטה למעלה.
והצעתי פה דרוש זה הגם שהם
דברים כבושים להיותם מאד
מסוגלים לכוין בהם לעולם
ובפרט סמוך ליציאת נשמה
בפסוק שמע ישראל.[i] וג׳ שמות
אלו מהם עדון תחתון עדון עליון
וצרורא דחיי מכוונים לג׳ מיני
לבושים וג׳ עדונים המתהוים
מזיהרא עילאה בהתעוררות
מיין נוקבין המעלין הצדיקים
מדי עסקם במצות בעובדא
ובמלולא ורעותא ובתקון
נפש רוח נשמה ובזה מתעלים
כל אחד מהם ליסוד יב״ק
העליון: אמרו על בן עזאי שלפי
שהיה חורז מתורה לנביאים
ומנביאים לכתובים[ii] היתה האש
מלהטת סביבותיו כי בהתדבקות
המחשבה מתוך האצילות ההוא
שהיה מאציל וממשיך עליו היו
הדברים מתוספים ומתרבים
ומתוך השמחה היו נגלים אליו
ומאירים בכח מקור נשמתו
שהיא למעלה בין הקדושים ע״כ
ערכתי סדרן של פסוקים אלו
החורזים מתורה ת״ת לנביאים
נ״ה ומנביאים לכתובים מלכות
ובזה אמריהם ישישו ויעלזו
לפני אלהים ויגדל כח אדנ״י.
וברי״מ פ׳ פנחס דף רי״ז מאי
להצהיל פנים משמן אינון י״ב
פנים מיכאל אריה ד׳ פנים
דיליה ידו״ד ד׳ פנים דשור
ואיהו גבריאל ואינון ידו״ד ד׳
פנים דנשר ואיהו אוריאל ואינון
ידו״ד ואינון ממנן תחות חסד
פחד אמת דרגין דתלת אבהן
ואוקמוה רבנן האבות הן הן
המרכבה וסלקין נהורין לחושבן

letter, and first letter spelling YaBOK. The name YeYA"I has its secret in Keter, and it is the complete unification, which clothes itself in the name Ehyeh, and the name YHVH clothes itself in Adny. There is also YHVH and Ehyeh in the mystery of "the head of the King," and YHVH and Adnut in the mystery of "the extension of the body," and these are one on the right and one on the left, unifying in the middle as mentioned in the Book [possibly Sefer Yetzirah], containing the mystery of unification from above to below and from below to above. 90R 95R

I have set forth this discourse here, even though these are concealed matters, because they are very beneficial to focus on at all times, and especially near the departure of the soul, during the recitation of the Shema Yisrael. These three names correspond to the lower paradise, the upper paradise, and the bond of life, which correspond to three types of garments and three delights that are formed from the supernal radiance through the awakening of the feminine waters that the righteous elevate during their engagement with commandments—in deed, in speech, and in thought—and in the rectification of soul, spirit, and higher soul, through which each of them is elevated to the foundation of the supernal YaBOK. 100R 105R 110R

They said of Ben Azzai that because he would string together teachings from Torah to Prophets and from Prophets to Writings, fire would blaze around him, for through the attachment of thought from that emanation that he would draw down upon himself, the matters would increase and multiply, and through joy they would be revealed to him and illuminate through the power of the source of his soul, which is above among the holy ones. Therefore, I have arranged the order of these verses, stringing them together from Torah (Tiferet) to Prophets (Netzach and Hod) and from Prophets to Writings (Malkhut), and through this their words will rejoice and exult before God, and the power of Adny will be magnified. 115R 120R 125R

In Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas, page 217, it asks: What is meant by "to make the face shine more than oil"? These are the twelve faces:

[i] The text emphasizes the special importance of reciting the Shema Yisrael prayer at the time of death, which aligns with traditional Jewish practice where this is considered the ideal final utterance.

[ii] The reference to Ben Azzai 'stringing together' teachings across the three divisions of Hebrew scripture represents a methodology of integrating all sacred texts into a unified system, which the author emulates in his own arrangement of verses.

יב״ק ואינון מלך מלך ימלוך שכל הוי״ה מנוקדת בנקודות ג׳ מלות אלו והוא סוד שם י״ב ומנייהו אתתקן גדפין ואנפין ועיינין גדפיו אדנ״י אנפוי הוי״ה עיינין אהי״ה. אדנ״י הוא לתקון המעשה הוי״ה לדבור אהי״ה למחשבה ויכוונו ליחד דבור בקול עם המחשבה העליונה ומשם לרעותא עילאה ובזה יתרבה אור עליון ויופיעו הרחמים ומיכאל וגבריאל רצים לגבי ההוא קלא דכתיב ורגליהם רגל ישרה. ובאתר דהוי״ה תמן הוא דרך ישרה: [i]

Michael is the lion with his four faces corresponding to YHVH; the four faces of the ox, which is Gabriel, corresponding to YHVH; the four faces of the eagle, which is Uriel, corresponding to YHVH. These are appointed beneath Chesed, Pachad, and Emet, the levels of the three Patriarchs, and the Rabbis established that "the Patriarchs themselves are the Chariot." The lights ascend to the numerical value of YaBOK, and they are "reigned," "reigns," "will reign," for each YHVH is vocalized with the vowels of these three words, and this is the mystery of the name of 12, and from them are established wings, faces, and eyes. The wings correspond to Adny, the faces to YHVH, and the eyes to Ehyeh. Adny is for the rectification of action, YHVH for speech, and Ehyeh for thought. They should have the intention to unify speech with voice and with the supernal thought, and from there to the supernal will, and through this supernal light will increase and mercy will shine forth.[1] Michael and Gabriel run toward that voice, as it is written, "And their legs were a straight leg" [Ezekiel 1:7]. And in the place where YHVH is found, there is the straight path.

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

על פי הדברים האלה נראה לעניות דעתי כי טוב לחלק פסוקים אלו לג׳ מערכות[ii] באמור ביניהם

Based on these principles, it seems to me in my humble opinion that it would be good to divide these verses into three arrangements, reciting between them one, two, or three of the designated psalms.

[1] The ultimate purpose of the mystical practice described here is to increase the flow of divine mercy and light to aid the sick or dying person in their transition.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The text cites the Zohar, specifically Parashat Pekudei, to establish the significance of Psalms 148 and 150 as encompassing all praises. This reference adds authoritative weight to the author's selection of specific psalms for the ritual. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas — The author quotes from Ra'aya Mehemna (a section of the Zohar) to explain the mystical significance of the twelve angelic faces and their correspondence to divine names. This reference establishes the connection between celestial forces and the numerical value of YaBOK (112). | Cf. Genesis 32:23 — The text references Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok river as the scriptural basis for the YaBOK acronym, establishing this biblical narrative as the foundation for the mystical concept of transitioning between spiritual realms. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4 (Shema Yisrael) — The Shema prayer is referenced as having special mystical significance, particularly near the time of death. The author analyzes its structure to reveal hidden divine names and unifications. | Cf. Sefer HaKaneh — The author references the kabbalistic work Sefer HaKaneh regarding the mystical properties of divine names, indicating that the current text is drawing on established kabbalistic literature rather than introducing entirely novel concepts. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:7 — The quote from Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah) connects the angelic beings to the divine names being discussed, reinforcing the relationship between heavenly forces and the mystical process described for assisting the sick or dying.

[ii] The author organizes his prayer system into three arrangements (ma'arachot), each corresponding to a divine name with specific numerical values. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that number,

א׳ או ב׳ או ג׳ מהמזמורים המצויינים. המערכה הראשונה תהיה מכ״א פסוקים כמספר אהי״ה אך טוב לישראל כי הוא חנון ורחום לכל פועל. המערכה השניה תהיה מכ״ו פסוקים כמספר שם הוי״ה ויכוין בנזכר. המערכה השלישית תהיה מס״ה פסוקים כמנין אדנ״י ויכוין כי ה׳ בהיכל קדשו ה״ס שהוא שם אדנו״ת[i] ובזה ישתקו פיות תחתונות המקטרגים ויחתו מגבורתם. וזהו וה׳ בהיכל קדשו אז ה״ס מפניו כל הארץ ומגמת פניו יהיה לתקון עליון נפש רוח לשמה של אותו העומד עליו בכח בטשת האורות הקדושים המתהוים מפיהם. המתפטר אם זוכה בכוונתו הטהורה מעלה מיין נוקבין בסוד נשמתו העולה ונפשות החיים שעומדים עליו מעוררים מיין דכורין עליו מלמעלה למטה.[ii] ולכן סדרי הפסוקים מתחיל לרמז והארת רוחניות משם אהי״ה ובטשת האורות מקדש האויר שעולים דרך בו ומפנים כחות הגורמים לו צער וחיל ובעתה מלבד כי מתהוה מהם שרפים ואופנים[iii] כנדרש בפ׳ פקודי ובכח נהורין אלין מעלין נשמת הנפטר על כנפי רוח ויפרשו כנפיהם יקחוהו וישאוהו על אברתם ועיין בריקנאט״י פ׳ וירא כי הדברים מתהוים באויר בסוד וכל העם רואים את הקולות ואמרו בפ׳ וילך כי דבריו של משה היו מתחקקים בשמא דקב״ה בדברי השירה

The first arrangement should consist of 21 verses, corresponding to the numerical value of the divine name “Ehyeh,” expressing that only good comes to Israel, for He is gracious and merciful to all His works. The second arrangement should consist of 26 verses, corresponding to the numerical value of the divine name YHVH, with the intention mentioned previously. The third arrangement should consist of 65 verses, corresponding to the numerical value of “Adonai,” with the intention that “the LORD is in His holy temple”—this is the secret of the divine name Adonut—and through this, the mouths of the lower accusers will be silenced, and they will be shattered from their might. This is the meaning of “the LORD is in His holy temple”—then “be silent before Him, all the earth.” One’s intention should be directed toward the supernal rectification of the soul, spirit, and higher soul of the person lying before him, through the impact of the holy lights that form from their mouths. 5R 10R 15R 20R

The departing one, if he merits through his pure intention, raises feminine waters through the mystery of his ascending soul, while the souls of the living who stand around him awaken masculine waters upon him from above to below. Therefore, the arrangements of verses begin by alluding to and illuminating spirituality from the divine name “Ehyeh.” The impact of these lights sanctifies the air through which they ascend and clears away the forces that cause suffering and trembling and terror. Moreover, from these verses are formed Seraphim and Ophanim, as expounded in Parashat Pekudei, and through the power of these lights, the soul of the departed is elevated on the wings of spirit. “And they shall spread their wings, take him, and carry him on their pinions.” 25R 30R 35R 40R

See Recanati on Parashat Vayera, for these things materialize in the air, as in the secret of “and all the people saw the voices.” And they said in

structure, and divine names are interconnected and have real spiritual power.

[i] H”S (ה״ס) stands for ‘ha-sod’ (the secret), indicating that the author is revealing an esoteric interpretation: that the phrase ‘the LORD is in His holy temple’ alludes to the divine name Adnut.

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic concept of mystical union, where ‘feminine waters’ (spiritual energy rising from below) meet ‘masculine waters’ (spiritual energy descending from above). In this context, the dying person’s soul provides the feminine aspect while those reciting prayers around him draw down the masculine aspect, creating a cosmic union that facilitates the soul’s transition.

[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that human speech, particularly of sacred texts, creates actual spiritual entities. The Seraphim and Ophanim are categories of angels described in Ezekiel’s vision of the divine chariot (merkavah).

והיינו דכתיב עד תומם ומזה
נבין כח ההבל הקדוש ואיך
מקדש ההבל הנשמה להיות היכל
לרוחניות המתהוה ממנו ועיין
בדברי ההוא מארי דקבין אשר
הובא בתקון ס״ט דף ק״ו ע״א
ובכח ההבל המסקל המסלה
תזכה ותיסק לאסתחיי׳ בעי
בוסמין עילאין דנגדי מתלת עשר
נהרי דאפרסמונא דכיא[i] לעדן
בהן נשמתייהו דצדיקיא אשר
נתגלה לר׳ אבהו בשעת פטירתו
אשרי העם שככה לו. עוד בסוד
ג׳ שמות אלו יש דברים עתיקים
להעלות הנשמה וכבר זכו בהם
מפי גורי האר״י זצ״ל שלמים
וכן רבים אשר זכו לשמש הגאון
מורי מפאנו זצ״ל[ii] בחלקם יהא
חלקי והם יוסיפו על הנדרש
עשר ידות. ופסוקים אלו נאותים
ליאמר בכוונה ודעת צלולה
לעורר רחמים על הנפטר
בשבעה ימים הראשונים [iii]

Parashat Vayelech that Moses' words were engraved in the name of the Holy One, blessed be He, in the words of the Song, as it is written: "until they were completed." From this, we understand the power of the holy breath and how the breath sanctifies the soul to become a sanctuary for the spirituality that forms from it. See the words of that master of measurements brought in Tikkun 69, page 106a. And through the power of the breath that clears the path, the soul merits to ascend and bathe in the supernal fragrances that flow from the thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil, in which the souls of the righteous delight, as was revealed to Rabbi Abahu at the time of his passing. Happy is the people that has it so.

There are furthermore ancient matters concerning these three divine names for elevating the soul, and many complete ones have already merited to receive them from the disciples of the ARI, of blessed memory, as well as those who merited to serve my teacher, the Gaon of Fano, of blessed memory. May my portion be among them, and they add tenfold to what is required. These verses are appropriate to be recited with proper intention and clear consciousness to arouse mercy for the departed during the first seven days.

ובסוף השלשים עם ההשכבה
וכן בכל י״ב חדש בעת שירצה
לעורר על מתו ולהזכיר נשמתו

At the end of thirty days with the Hashkavah prayer,[1] and throughout the twelve months whenever one wishes to arouse remembrance for their

[1] The Hashkavah is a memorial prayer for the repose of the soul, recited at the grave and during subsequent memorial services.

[i] The 'rivers of pure balsam oil' represent a celestial realm where righteous souls are cleansed and refreshed after death. This image appears frequently in the Zohar and other kabbalistic texts as a metaphor for spiritual purification and delight in the afterlife.

[ii] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an Italian kabbalist who synthesized the teachings of Moses Cordovero and Isaac Luria. This reference confirms the author's intellectual lineage and places Ma'avar Yabok within the tradition of Italian Kabbalah influenced by Lurianic teachings.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage appears in the fourth section of Ma'avar Yabok, providing instructions for structuring prayers to aid the soul's transition. The author is organizing a prayer system using divine names as its framework. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author references this kabbalistic text to support his explanation of how holy breath/speech creates spiritual entities and sanctifies the soul. | Cf. Zohar — The author cites this section of the Zohar to explain how recited verses create spiritual entities (Seraphim and Ophanim) that assist the departing soul's ascent. | Cf. Commentary of Recanati — The author references Rabbi Menahem Recanati's kabbalistic commentary to explain how spoken words materialize spiritual realities in the air. | Cf. Writings of Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano — The author mentions his teacher, the Gaon of Fano (Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano), indicating that deeper teachings about these three divine names exist in his tradition.

לפני קונו ובפרט בג׳ לבכי
באשר הזכרנו למעלה. אמרו
דורשי רשומות כי צריך להזהר
שבעת המות לא ישאר בלום
מאבריו חוץ למטה כי כל הנשאר
ממנו חוץ לזאת המטה לא יאסף
ולא יקבר לחית השדה נתתיהו
לאכלה[i] וזה לפי שבסביבות
המטה הנזכר יש מיני משחית
ופורענות בד״א כשושנה בין
החוחים[ii] לפיכך צריך שיאסף
אל עמיו ולא חוץ לבחות
הטומאה. וכן צריך ליזהר
שהרצועה של יד לא תהיה תלויה
רק יכרכנה סביב הזרוע והטעם
כי רגליה יורדות מות[iii] וסמך
לזה מה שאמרו בשבת ובלבד
שלא תצא רצועה מתחת ידו
טפח. וצריך אותו אבר הנשאר
חוץ לסבול יסורים רבים עד כי
יוכל להכנס בפנים והוא נקראת
פליטת הגלגל[iv] ובזה נבין עג
עוגה ועמד בתוכה.[v] וזהו ענין
אסיפה הנאמרת בצדיקים מלבד
הנדרש עליו שהוא אסיפת נשמתו
להיכלי הקדושה ולאבותיו
ולחביריו הקדושים ומידי עברה
בועטת כל בחות הדין המנגדים
אותה בקולה הגדול שהולכת

deceased and mention their soul before their Creator, especially during the three days of weeping[1] as we mentioned above. Those who interpret sacred texts have said that one must be careful that at the time of death, none of the person's limbs remain outside the bed, for whatever remains outside this bed will not be gathered or buried, but "to the beasts of the field I have given it for food." This is because surrounding the aforementioned bed are various destructive and punishing forces, as it says, "Like a lily among thorns." Therefore, one must be gathered to their peop[2]le and not [remain] outside among the forces of impurity. Similarly, one must be careful that the tefillin strap of the hand not dangle but rather be wrapped around the arm, because "her feet descend to death,"[3] and this is supported by what they said in [Tractate] Shabbat: "provided that the strap does not extend a handbreadth beyond his hand." The limb that remains outside must endure many sufferings until it can enter within, and this is called "the escape of the wheel,"[4] and through this we understand [the verse] "Draw a circle and stand within it." This is the concept of "gathering" mentioned regarding the righteous, besides its interpretation that it refers to the gathering of his soul to the chambers of holiness, to his ancestors, and to his holy companions. As it passes through, it kicks away all the forces of judgment that oppose it with its great voice that

[1]The tradition recognizes different stages of mourning, with the first three days considered the most intense period for grief and weeping.
[2]This phrase echoes the biblical expression used to describe the death of patriarchs (e.g., 'Abraham was gathered to his people'), which the author interprets both literally (regarding the physical body) and spiritually (regarding the soul's journey).
[3]This is a direct quote from Proverbs 5:5, which in its original context refers to the dangerous woman/strange woman, but is applied here to the dangling tefillin strap.
[4]This obscure term appears to be a kabbalistic concept referring to something that exits its proper boundaries or orbit. The exact meaning is unclear even in context.

[i]This uses biblical language to emphasize the spiritual danger of body parts extending beyond the protective boundary of the deathbed, comparing them to unburied corpses left as prey.
[ii]A reference to Song of Songs 2:2. In its original context, this verse compares the beloved to a lily among thorns, but here it's repurposed to describe the vulnerable position of the dying person surrounded by harmful spiritual forces.
[iii]A quote from Proverbs 5:5, which originally warns against the dangerous woman whose path leads to death. Here, it's applied to the dangling tefillin strap as a metaphor for spiritual danger.
[iv]This appears to be a kabbalistic term unique to this context, relating to parts of the soul or body that escape proper boundaries during the death process.
[v]This alludes to the famous Talmudic story of Honi HaMe'agel (Honi the Circle-Drawer), who drew a circle around himself and stood within it during prayer. The reference suggests that the bed serves as a protective circle for the dying person.

מסוף העולם ועד סופו כדאמרו
בקולות הרוגי מלכות[i] שהיו
מכוונים להתיש הקליפות
בקולם העצום פן יתגברו עליהם
מתוך צערם וכן אמרו במ״ר
פ״ו נפשיה דההוא גברא מקצצא
ארזין ומקצצא אילנין.[ii] ועל
העומדים עליו מוטל להיות
עיניהם פקוחות על זה שלא יצאו
מאבריו חוץ למטה.[iii]

travels from one end of the world to the other,[1] as they said regarding the voices of those executed by the government, who would intentionally weaken the negative forces with their powerful cry lest these forces overpower them in their suffering. Similarly, they said in Midrash Rabbah chapter 6: "The soul of that man cuts down cedars and cuts down trees."[2] It is incumbent upon those attending the dying person to keep their eyes open to ensure that none of his limbs extend outside the bed.

מצאתי קצת סמך על מנהג
ישראל שלא לעמוד לרגלי
המטה שבו הגוסס ישן כי מ״ה
כנגדו וחרבו בידו[iv] כדאמרו
רבנן ואין להתקרב אליו ולא
לדחוק מקומו. וכתוב בזהר פ׳
פנחס דף רל״ד ע״ב המבקר את
החולה לא ליהוב מראשותיו
משום דשבינתא על רישיה ולא
לרגלוהי דמ״ה לרגלוהי. האי
לאו לכל בר ישראל אלא לבינוני
אבל לצדיק גמור ה׳ יסעדנו

I found some support for the Jewish custom not to stand at the foot of the bed where a dying person lies, since the Angel of Death stands opposite him with sword in hand, as our Sages stated. One should not approach him nor crowd his space. It is written in the Zohar, Parashat Pinchas, page 234b: "One who visits the sick should not sit at his head, because the Divine Presence is at his head, nor at his feet, for the Angel of Death is at his feet. This applies not to every Israelite, but to the average person. However, for the completely righteous, 'The Lord will support him upon the bed of illness' (Psalms 41:4)—at his

[1] This hyperbolic expression emphasizes the tremendous spiritual power released at the moment of death, when the soul departs the body.

[2] This colorful metaphor from the Midrash illustrates the tremendous spiritual force of the departing soul, portrayed as having such power that it can metaphorically uproot mighty trees.

[i] This refers to Jewish martyrs executed by Roman authorities, who according to tradition would intentionally cry out at the moment of death to weaken harmful spiritual forces.

[ii] An Aramaic phrase meaning 'the soul of that man cuts down cedars and cuts down trees,' illustrating the tremendous spiritual power released at the moment of death.

[iii] Cf. Hashkavah prayer — The author is referring to the traditional prayer for the repose of the soul, which is recited at the grave, during the seven days of mourning, and at memorial services throughout the year following death. | Cf. to the beasts of the field I have given it for food — The author uses this biblical-style language to emphasize that parts of the body left outside proper ritual boundaries are spiritually vulnerable, comparing them to carcasses left for wild animals. | Cf. Like a lily among thorns — The author repurposes this verse to illustrate how the dying person (compared to the lily) is surrounded by harmful spiritual forces (the thorns). This creates a powerful image of vulnerability requiring protection. | Cf. her feet descend to death — This verse is applied to the dangling tefillin strap as a metaphor—just as the woman's feet lead to death in Proverbs, a hanging strap creates spiritual danger. This shows how the author finds mystical significance in practical ritual details. | Cf. Shabbat — The author cites Talmudic authority to support his mystical instruction, showing how Ma'avar Yabok integrates halakhic (legal) sources with kabbalistic interpretations. | Cf. Draw a circle and stand within it — The author uses this well-known Talmudic reference to illustrate the concept of creating a protective boundary. Just as Honi drew a circle for protection during prayer, the bed serves as a protective circle for the dying person. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah chapter 6 — The author cites this midrash to demonstrate the tremendous spiritual power of the soul as it departs the body, portrayed as having such force that it can metaphorically cut down trees.

[iv] Here, M"H is an abbreviation used for Malakh HaMavet (Angel of Death). The text references the talmudic concept that the Angel of Death stands at the foot of a dying person's bed with drawn sword.

על ערש דוי על רישיה ושכינתא
אסחר גופיה עד רגלוהי. רשע
גמור מדת הדין אסחר ליה בכל
סטרא ודא יצר הרע רחמנא
125 ליצלן. ואי זכה נחית בדמות
אריה לקבלא נשמתיה[i] ואי לא
זכה נחית בדמות כלב[ii] וזהו
מיד כלב יחידתי. ובתקון י״ח
דף ל״א ע״ב אית רעש דלא ייתי
130 תמן קב״ה ואית רעש דייתי תמן
ורעש בהפוכא ערש ומאי כל
משכבו הפכת בחליו. דאתהפך
רעש לערש דאיהו ערש בהיפוך
אתוון ודא שכינתא דאיהי כללא
135 דעשר ספירן דעלה אתמר אין
קדושה בפחות מעשר[iii] דאיהי
שריא לרישא דחולה ובגין כך
ה׳ יסעדנו ובמאי על ערש
דוי על שכינתיה ודאי ואי
140 שכינתא לאו תמן רוח סערה
תמן דאסעיר גופיה דבר נש
דכתיב ביה האניה דחיינו גופא
חשבה להשבר דלית שכינא
דסמיכת ליה ובזמנא דשכינתא
145 סמיכת ליה מיד קלא נפיק בן
אדם עמוד על רגליך וקאים
ממרעא דיליה ונפיק מדינא
שלים בגופיה שלים בממוניה.
ואי לא דמסתפינא אמינא כי
150 אפילו אותם הנהרגים בידי אדם
מלאך המות מקדים לבא שם
ואולי מתלבש ברוצח[iv] והוא
חרבו של מלאך המות אך באמת

head—and the Divine Presence surrounds his body down to his feet. For the completely wicked, the attribute of judgment surrounds him on all sides, and this is the evil inclination—may the Merciful One save us.[A] If he merits, the Angel of Death descends in the form of a lion to receive his soul, but if he does not merit, it descends in the form of a dog, and this is the meaning of 'Deliver my soul from the sword, my only one from the power of the dog' (Psalms 22:21)." 125R 130R

And in Tikkun 18, page 31b: "There is a 'tumult' (ra'ash) where the Holy One, blessed be He, does not come, and there is a 'tumult' where He does come. And 'ra'ash' (tumult) is the reverse of 'eres' (bed), and what is meant by 'You have transformed his entire bed in his illness' (Psalms 41:4)? That 'ra'ash' (tumult) is transformed into 'eres' (bed), which is 'eres' with the letters reversed. And this refers to the Divine Presence, which encompasses the ten sefirot, concerning which it is said, 'There is no holiness with fewer than ten.' She rests at the head of the sick person, and therefore 'The Lord will support him,' and how? 'Upon the bed of illness'—upon His Divine Presence, certainly. And if the Divine Presence is not there, then a stormy wind is there, which tosses the person's body, of which it is written, 'The ship'—meaning the body—'thought it would break,' because there is no Divine Presence supporting him. And when the Divine Presence supports him, immediately a voice emerges: 'Son of man, stand upon your feet,' and he rises from his illness and emerges from judgment whole in body and whole in possessions." 135R 140R 145R 150R 155R

And if I were not afraid, I would say that even

[A] Or: "the attribute of judgment encircles him from every direction, which is the evil inclination—may God protect us from this" — This alternative uses 'encircles' and 'from every direction' which might better convey the image of complete spiritual encirclement. It also renders the Aramaic prayer formula in more standard English. This might be preferred in contexts where the reader has less familiarity with traditional Jewish prayer formulations.

[i] This presents a kabbalistic concept that the Angel of Death appears in different forms depending on the spiritual merit of the dying person—as a lion for the meritorious, which would be a more dignified departure.

[ii] The form of a dog represents a less dignified departure for those who didn't merit the more noble form of the lion. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the manner of one's death corresponds to their spiritual state.

[iii] This references the principle that certain sacred prayers require a minyan (quorum of ten Jewish adults), connecting this requirement to the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah.

[iv] This presents a complex theological understanding of murder, suggesting that even when someone is killed by human hands, the Angel of Death is somehow involved, perhaps by 'clothing himself' in the murderer. However, the text is careful to maintain human free will and responsibility by noting that the murderer acts of his own volition.

אין מלאך המות מושל בו ברצונו
כי רשע זה קודמו. וגם שמדברי
ספר הזהר בסוד עגלה ערופה
לבאורה אין נראה כן. מ״מ
בשישקף בטוב העיון לא יחלוק
על סברתנו זאת: [i]

those killed by human hands—the Angel of Death comes there first[A] and perhaps clothes himself in the murderer, who becomes the sword of the Angel of Death. But in truth, the Angel of Death does not rule over him by his own will, for this wicked person preceded him.[B] And although from the words of the Zohar regarding the mystery of the heifer whose neck is broken, it would appear not to be so, nevertheless, when examined with good analysis, it would not disagree with this opinion of ours.

פרק ז׳

Chapter 7

פרק ז׳ וח׳ היב״ק[ii] פסוקים
עם הנמשכים אחריהם והתפילה
השייכה בשעת יציאת נשמה כבר
באו בתחילת הספר למען לא
יהיו עיני הקורא משוטטות וכל
החפץ יכול למלאת ידו לזכות
את הרבים[iii] לעשות חסד עם

Chapters 7 and 8 of Ma'avar Yabok, containing verses with their following passages and the prayer appropriate for the moment of the soul's departure, have already appeared at the beginning of the book[1] so that the reader's eyes need not wander. Anyone who desires may fulfill their duty to bring merit to the community by performing kindness

[A] Or: "And were I not hesitant, I would suggest that even in cases of murder, the Angel of Death arrives beforehand" — This alternative is more conversational and direct, avoiding the slightly awkward construction of the original translation. It might be preferable in contexts where clarity is prioritized over preserving the distinctive voice of mystical texts.

[B] Or: "the Angel of Death has no autonomous authority in this case, as the murderer's evil will has preempted the divine decree" — This alternative more clearly expresses the theological point being made about the relationship between divine and human agency in cases of murder. It might be preferred in contexts where theological precision is more important than literal translation.

[1] The author is creating a cross-reference system within his book, acknowledging that he has placed the same material in multiple locations to make it more accessible for practical use during deathbed situations.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas 234b — This text is foundational to the Jewish practice of not standing at the foot of a sick person's bed. The Zohar establishes a spiritual geography around the sickbed, with the Divine Presence at the head and the Angel of Death at the feet, and offers different arrangements for the righteous, average, and wicked individuals. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 18, 31b — This text provides a kabbalistic interpretation of Psalm 41:4 through letter reversals (notarikon), showing how the Divine Presence transforms the chaotic energy of sickness (ra'ash/tumult) into healing support (eres/bed). It emphasizes the importance of a minyan (ten people) for creating a sacred space that allows divine energy to support healing. | Cf. Psalms 41:4 — The author uses this verse as a scriptural basis for the spiritual dynamics around a sickbed, particularly the idea that God's presence provides support to the ill person. | Cf. Psalms 22:21 — The text interprets this verse metaphysically, suggesting that the 'dog' refers to the form the Angel of Death takes when collecting the soul of someone who did not merit a more dignified transition. | Cf. Ezekiel 2:1 — The text repurposes this prophetic command as a healing declaration that comes when the Divine Presence supports the sick person, causing them to recover from their illness.

[ii] This is an acronym for the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (מעבר יבק). The numerical value of these letters (יב״ק) equals 112, which corresponds to the specific collection of verses to be recited at the time of death.

[iii] This phrase refers to bringing merit to the community, a concept in Jewish thought where performing mitzvot (commandments) benefits not just the individual but the entire Jewish community. Here it specifically refers to the merit gained by performing proper death rituals.

החיים ועם המתים:[i] with both the living and the dead.[1]

פרק ט׳

Chapter 9

טעם עצימת הבן עיני אביו ותועלת המגיע מזה לנפטר,[ii] עיין פ׳ שלח דף קס״ט כדי דליהוי ליה חיזו וחולקא דההוא עלמא דלא זכי לדא עד דאסתים מניה כל חיזו דהאי עלמא ולבן אפילו בשאין לנפטר בן מצוה לעומדים שם לסתו׳ עיניו וטוב שהיורש ממונו יעשה לו תקון זה. ואם זכית לסוד רמז תורת הנחלה בעולם העליון תבין טעם זה וכן למה אסור להעביר נחלה אפילו מברא בישא לברא טבא.[iii] ויש בעצימת העין של מת טעמים אחרים ואחד מהם לבל יחזי חיזו אחרא בתר חיזו דשבינתא[iv] עוד אמרו בזה דברים עתיקים ובפרט בפ׳ ויחי דף רכ״ו ע״א ומשם נראה שראוי לבן לנגרא עפר על עיני

The reason for a son closing his father's eyes and the benefit that accrues to the deceased: See Parashat Shelach, page 169, "so that he may have vision and a portion in that world,[A] for he does not merit this until all vision of this world is closed from him."[2] Therefore, even when the deceased has no son, it is a duty for those present to close his eyes, and it is good that the one who inherits his property should perform this rectification[B] for him. And if you have merited to understand the secret allusion of the Torah of inheritance in the supernal world, you will understand this reason, and also why it is forbidden to transfer an inheritance even from a wicked son to a righteous son.

There are other reasons for closing the eyes of the dead, and one of them is so that he will not see another vision after the vision of the Divine Presence. They have also said ancient things about this, particularly in Parashat Vayechi, page 226a, from which it appears appropriate for a son to pour earth over

[A] Or: "so that he may receive sight and a share in the World to Come" — This alternative translation emphasizes the eschatological aspect of 'that world' (ההוא עלמא) by using the more explicitly religious term 'World to Come'. It also uses 'receive sight' instead of 'have vision' to better convey the transformative nature of the soul's new perception.

[B] Or: "this spiritual correction" — While 'rectification' is a common translation of 'תקון' (tikkun), 'spiritual correction' more explicitly conveys the kabbalistic concept that these actions repair or adjust something in the spiritual realm.

[1] This refers to the concept of 'chesed shel emet' (true kindness), which is how Jewish tradition describes care for the dead. It is considered the purest form of kindness because the recipient cannot reciprocate or thank the giver.

[2] The original contains the Aramaic phrase 'דאסתים מניה כל חיזו דהאי עלמא', which literally means 'until all vision of this world is closed/sealed from him'. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the soul must detach from physical perception before it can fully perceive spiritual realms.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author is referencing earlier sections of his own work where he already included the materials mentioned here, suggesting an organized structure where he doesn't want to repeat content unnecessarily but wants to help readers locate important ritual texts. | Cf. Gemilut Chasadim (Acts of Loving-kindness) — The concept of 'doing kindness with the living and the dead' refers to the Jewish value of gemilut chasadim, particularly as applied to proper care for the dying and deceased, which is one of the highest forms of kindness as it cannot be reciprocated.

[ii] The text emphasizes not just the ritual action but its spiritual benefit for the deceased, showing how physical actions in this world affect the soul's journey in the next.

[iii] This references a halakhic principle forbidding disinheriting even a wicked son in favor of a righteous one, which Ma'avar Yabok connects to mystical principles of inheritance in the supernal worlds.

[iv] This reveals a profound kabbalistic concept: the deceased first sees the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) at death, and closing the eyes prevents subsequent lesser visions that might diminish this spiritual experience.

דאבוי כד אתקבר. ואם יש לו עפר א״י טוב שהבן ישים אותה בעצמו על עיניו ואמר כי סתימת העינים ע״י הבן הוא סיוע לדינא דקברא.[i] וכבר דברנו מזה למעלה בחלק א׳. אחר פטירת המת מתוך ד״ת יקיימו מצות הקריעה [ii]

his father's eyes when he is buried.[A] And if he has earth from the Land of Israel,[1] it is good that the son should place it himself over his eyes. And it was said that the closing of the eyes by the son assists with the judgment of the grave. And we have already discussed this above in Part One. After the deceased's passing, while engaged in words of Torah,[2] they shall fulfill the commandment of tearing [garments].

25R

דאמר רשב״א העומד על המת בשעת יציאת נשמה חייב לקרוע הא למה זה דומה לס״ת שנשרף שהכל חייבים לקרוע ופי׳ הרמב״ן כי נפש בגוף באזכרות בגויליין[iii] ומשל הוא לומר שהוא הפסד גדול וחרדה רבה וחייב לקרוע עליו כאלו נשרף ס״ת לפניו אי נמי יש לומר כשם שקורעין עליה

For Rabbi Shlomo ben Aderet said:[3] One who stands over the deceased at the moment of the soul's departure is obligated to tear [his garment]. To what can this be compared? To a Torah scroll that is burned, for which everyone is obligated to tear [their garments]. The Ramban explained[4] that the soul in the body is like the divine names written on parchment.[B] This is a metaphor indicating that it is a great loss and a profound distress, and one is obligated to tear for him as if a Torah scroll

30R

35R

[A] Or: "to sprinkle earth upon his father's eyes at the time of burial" — The Aramaic term 'לנגרא' (to pour) might be more precisely translated as 'to sprinkle' in this ritual context. This alternative more clearly suggests the careful, deliberate nature of this act rather than simply pouring.

[B] Or: "the soul in the body is like the sacred divine names inscribed on the parchment scrolls" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the sacred nature of the divine names (azkarot) and clarifies that 'gevilin' specifically refers to parchment scrolls used for Torah writing. This might be preferable for readers less familiar with the technical terminology of Torah scroll production.

[1] The Hebrew term 'עפר א״י' refers specifically to soil from the Holy Land, which is considered to have special sanctity and spiritual potency in Jewish tradition.

[2] The Hebrew abbreviation 'ד״ת' (divrei Torah) refers to engagement with sacred texts and religious discussion. The passage suggests that the tearing of garments (kriah) should take place while those present are engaged in sacred study.

[3] The Hebrew uses the acronym 'Rashba,' which I have expanded to his full name for clarity. Rabbi Shlomo ben Aderet (1235-1310) was a prominent Spanish Talmudist and halakhic authority.

[4] Rabbi Moses ben Nachman (1194-1270), known as Nachmanides or Ramban, was a leading medieval Jewish scholar. His explanation adds theological depth to the ritual practice of tearing garments.

[i] The 'judgment of the grave' (dina d'kivra) refers to the initial spiritual judgment that occurs immediately after burial, when the soul is still closely connected to the body.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shelach — The Zohar explains that closing a deceased person's eyes helps them transition to the next world by shutting out visions of this world, enabling them to perceive the spiritual realm. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — This section of the Zohar elaborates on burial practices, specifically the custom of a son placing earth on his father's eyes, which is understood to assist with the 'judgment of the grave' (dina d'kivra), a spiritual process the soul undergoes after death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part One — The author refers back to his own previous discussion of this topic in an earlier section of Ma'avar Yabok, showing how the work builds upon itself with recurring themes related to death rituals.

[iii] This is a profound metaphor comparing the soul's relationship to the body with the divine names' relationship to Torah parchment. In Jewish tradition, the divine names (azkarot) written in a Torah scroll are its most sacred element, just as the soul is the most sacred element of a person.

קורעין על מקיימי מצותיה
שבשריפתה אובדין מצות של
כתיבה ובמיתת עושיה אובדים
מצות של מעשה הילכך על כל
אדם מישראל קורעין ואפילו
על אשה. עוד נוכל לומר כי
טעם הקריעה יהיה לסייע למת
להפשיט מעליו לבוש הגשמי
להכינו ללבוש חלוקא דרבנן.
והיא בצואר להורות כי לבוש זה
איצו עוד דבק עם נשמתו כעור
הצואר שנפשט מעצמו כדאמרי׳
במשנת העור והרוטב. ועוד
כי עקר ההתלבשות במדרגות
הקדושה היא מבחינת הצואר
ולמטה דבסוד רישא דורשים
דרשות אחרים[i] ובכמה בחינות
הראש עומד בעצמו ואינו
מתפשט ומתלבש כמו מהצואר
ולמטה ועומדים בשעת הקריעה
ויכוונו להעלותו מעלמא
דנוקבא שהיה בו על ידי הלבוש
הזה התחתון החומרי לעלמא
דדכורא[ii] להלביש נשמתו ורוחו
ונפשו מחלצות מזיהר׳ עילאה
כדאמרו בטעם ספירת העומר
מעומד. ויאמרו בשעת הקריעה

were burned before him.[1] Alternatively, one could say that just as we tear for it [the Torah], we tear for those who fulfill its commandments, for in its burning, the commandments of writing are lost, and in the death of those who perform them, the commandments of action are lost. Therefore, we tear for every person of Israel, even for a woman.

We can further explain that the purpose of tearing is to assist the deceased in removing his physical garment and preparing him to don the scholarly robe[2] [in the afterlife]. The tear is made at the neck to indicate that this garment is no longer attached to his soul, like the skin of the neck that is easily removed, as we say in the Mishnah of "The Skin and the Broth." Additionally, the primary clothing in the levels of holiness begins from the aspect of the neck downward, for regarding the mystery of the head, there are different interpretations, and in several aspects, the head stands on its own and does not extend and clothe itself as it does from the neck downward.

One stands during the tearing and should intend to elevate the deceased from the feminine realm, in which he existed through this lower, material garment, to the masculine realm,[A] to clothe his soul, spirit, and life-force in pure garments from the supernal radiance,[B] as they said regarding the

[A] Or: "to elevate him from the passive, receptive realm in which he existed through this lower, material garment, to the active, giving realm" — This alternate translation emphasizes the active/passive dichotomy in Kabbalistic cosmology rather than using the gendered terminology of 'feminine' and 'masculine' realms. This might be preferable in contexts where a more conceptual rather than gendered explanation is desired, though it loses some of the technical precision of the original kabbalistic terminology.

[B] Or: "vestments of light from the celestial illumination" — This alternate translation captures the mystical imagery more vividly by using 'vestments of light' for 'machaltzot' and 'celestial illumination' for 'zihara ila'ah'. This might be preferable in contexts where the poetic and mystical dimensions of the text are being emphasized.

[1] The comparison between witnessing death and seeing a Torah scroll burn illustrates the Jewish view that human life has sacred value comparable to the Torah itself, as humans are created in God's image and the body houses the divine soul.

[2] The Hebrew term 'chaluka d'rabbanan' literally means 'the garment of the scholars' and refers to the spiritual garment that clothes the soul in the afterlife, earned through Torah study and good deeds in this world. This is a mystical concept not to be understood literally.

[i] This reflects a kabbalistic concept that the head represents higher spiritual realms that remain somewhat separate and autonomous, while from the neck downward represents realms that are more directly involved with the lower worlds. This explains why the tear is made at the neck specifically.

[ii] This expresses the kabbalistic understanding that physical existence is associated with the 'feminine realm' (characterized by receptivity and judgment), while spiritual existence after death transitions to the 'masculine realm' (characterized by bestowal and mercy). The tearing ritual symbolically assists this transition.

פסוק ה׳ נתן וה׳ לקח יהי שם ה׳ מבורך. הצור תמים פעלו וגו׳. והלך לפניך צדקך כבוד ה׳ יאספך. תשכב בשלום ותישן בשלום וכו׳. ויכסו פני המת לבל יביטו המקטרגים בפניו ובמצחו ששם נרשמים העונות[i] ויוסיפו לו מכאוב [ii]

reason for counting the Omer while standing.[1] And they should say at the time of the tearing the verse: "The Lord gave, and the Lord has taken away; blessed be the name of the Lord." [And] "The Rock, His work is perfect, etc." And "Your righteousness shall go before you; the glory of the Lord shall gather you in." "May you lie in peace and sleep in peace, etc." And they should cover the face of the deceased so that the accusers will not look upon his face and forehead, where sins are recorded, and add to his suffering.

ואפילו האדם החי טוב לכסות מצחו לעולם שלא יתראה בפני החיצונים ועוד שאסור להסתכל בפני המת פן יתבזה בעיניו ועוד אין להשפיע ראיית העין שהוא רמז לבת עין העליונה במקום המיתה ח״ו[iii] כי אור העין שואב משם להיותה במראה הלטושה ולא המתים יהללו יה ולבן אמר

Even for a living person, it is good to cover his forehead at all times so that it is not visible to the external forces.[2] Furthermore, it is forbidden to gaze at the face of the dead lest he be dishonored in one's eyes.[A] Additionally, one should not direct the gaze of the eye, which symbolizes the supernal pupil, toward the place of death, God forbid, because the light of the eye draws from there, being like a polished mirror, and "the dead do not praise the

[A] Or: "Furthermore, it is forbidden to look at the face of the deceased lest it cause the deceased to be dishonored in one's perception" — This alternative translation shifts the focus to the action's effect on the deceased's dignity rather than implying that the deceased might feel dishonor. It also uses 'deceased' instead of 'dead,' which may be considered more respectful in modern English.

[1] This refers to the Jewish practice of counting the 49 days between Passover and Shavuot while standing. The text draws a parallel between this practice and standing during the tearing ritual, suggesting both involve elevation to higher spiritual states.

[2] The text suggests that the forehead (metzach) is spiritually vulnerable, as it is believed in Jewish mysticism to reveal one's sins or spiritual state. Covering it protects from negative spiritual forces (chitzonim) that might exploit these spiritual vulnerabilities.

[i] According to kabbalistic tradition, a person's sins are recorded on their forehead, visible to spiritual beings even if not to humans. This explains the custom of covering the deceased's face promptly.

[ii] Cf. Job 1:21 — This verse from Job affirms acceptance of divine judgment even in the face of loss, making it appropriate for the moment of tearing garments upon witnessing death. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:4 — This verse affirms divine justice and perfection, helping mourners accept death as part of God's perfect plan, even when it seems difficult to understand. | Cf. Isaiah 58:8 — This verse offers comfort by suggesting that the deceased's righteousness will precede them in the afterlife, and God's glory will receive them. | Cf. Chullin 122a — The author uses this Talmudic passage about how animal skin naturally separates from flesh as an analogy for how the physical body (garment) naturally separates from the soul at death. | Cf. Zohar — The text uses Zoharic terminology where 'feminine realm' (עלמא דנוקבא) refers to the material world associated with mortality and judgment, while the 'masculine realm' (עלמא דדכורא) refers to the spiritual world associated with mercy and eternal life. The tearing ritual is understood as facilitating this transition. | Cf. Moed Katan 25a — The author cites Rabbi Shlomo ben Aderet (Rashba) interpreting this Talmudic passage, which compares witnessing death to seeing a Torah scroll burn, both requiring the tearing of garments as a sign of mourning for a profound spiritual loss.

[iii] This passage reveals a kabbalistic understanding of vision where the human eye is mystically connected to divine sight ("the supernal pupil"). The text warns against directing this power toward death, as it creates an inappropriate connection between divine vision and the realm of death.

לשון הסתכלות שהוא ראיה
בהבטה תמידית כי אז פוגם
עינו וח״ו מפריד ברמז העין
כי רגליה דווקא יורדות בקצת
להתלבש בסוד המות לאבנעא
לאינון קליפין כדכתיב ומלכותו
בכל משלה לא בחינת העינים
כי עיני ה׳ אל יראיו למיחלים
לחסדו וגורמים היחוד לכנסת
ישראל.[i] טעם למנהג שימת המת
בקרקע[ii] הוא כי קרקע עולם
אינו מקבל לא טומאת מת ולא
טומאת מדרס[iii] כדאמרי׳ במס׳
נדה וכלים וראייתם מפסוק
ונקתה לארץ תשב ואם יניחו
המת במטה או ישימוהו על גבי
שלחן וכלים הראויים לקבל
טומאה כ״ש שידרסו ויחזיקו
בו הרוחות כי אין המטה טפלה
למת כדאמרי׳ במס׳ שבת פרק
המצניע. מלבד כי רמז הקרקע
הוא במלכות שבה נטועים כל
הנטיעות וגם יסוד בהיותו
משך וא״ו נקרא קרקע ערבות
ת״ת[iv] ועוד שכל דבר מתאוה
לחזור למקורו וזהו מנוחתו
עליונים תאבים לעלות למעלה

Lord." Therefore, the term "gazing" is used, which refers to continuous, fixed looking, for then one damages his eye and, God forbid, creates separation in the symbolic realm of sight.[1] For only "her feet" [referring to Malkhut] descend partially to clothe themselves in the mystery of death to subdue those husks [kelipot],[A] as it is written, "and His kingdom rules over all"—but not the aspect of the eyes, for "the eyes of the Lord are toward those who fear Him, to those who hope for His kindness," and they cause unification for the Community of Israel. 90R 95R

The reason for the custom of placing the deceased on the ground is that the earth does not receive impurity from a corpse nor the impurity of treading, as stated in the tractates of Niddah and Kelim, with their proof from the verse "and she shall sit on the ground and be cleansed." If they were to place the deceased on a bed or on a table and vessels that can receive impurity, all the more so would the spirits trample upon and take hold of him, for the bed is not subordinate to the deceased, as stated in the tractate of Shabbat, chapter HaMatznia. 100R 105R

Moreover, the symbolism of the ground is found in Malkhut, in which all plantings are rooted, and also Yesod, being an extension of Vav, is called the ground of Aravot of Tiferet. Additionally, everything desires to return to its source, and this is its 110R

[A] Or: "For specifically "her feet" [Malkhut/Divine Kingdom] alone descend somewhat to become clothed in the mystery of death in order to subdue those negative forces [kelipot]" — This alternative makes explicit the identification of 'her feet' with Malkhut as the Divine Kingdom and clarifies the purpose of this descent as subduing negative forces rather than merely 'husks,' which might not convey the full meaning of 'kelipot' to non-specialists.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that visual perception has spiritual consequences. Fixed gazing at the dead is seen as creating an inappropriate mystical connection between the realms of life and death that damages the observer's spiritual faculties and disrupts cosmic harmony.

[i] This presents a complex kabbalistic cosmology where different divine attributes have distinct relationships with death: Malkhut (Kingdom) can interact with death to subdue negative forces, but attributes associated with divine sight and mercy must remain separated from death to maintain proper cosmic order.

[ii] The text now shifts from mystical explanations about vision to explaining the practical ritual of placing the deceased directly on the ground, demonstrating how Ma'avar Yabok consistently provides both practical guidance and mystical rationales for Jewish burial practices.

[iii] This refers to a Talmudic principle that ground which is attached to the earth does not receive ritual impurity, unlike movable objects which can become ritually impure through contact with a corpse or through being stepped on by certain categories of ritually impure people.

[iv] This passage employs dense kabbalistic terminology to explain that placing the body on the ground symbolically connects it to divine attributes (sefirot) that facilitate proper spiritual transitions after death. The ground represents Malkhut (divine kingship), which is connected to Yesod (foundation) and ultimately to Tiferet (harmony) through the mystical celestial realm called Aravot.

שהם נפש רוח ונשמה ותחתונים תאבים לרדת למטה שהם אברי הגוף[i] כי עפר הוא ואל עפר ישוב והגוף הוא בחינת הזכר המשפיע על הנקבה עפרא דארעא: בעת שמשימים אותו בארץ יכסוהו בסדין כנהוג להעלימו מכחות הדין כנ״ל [ii]

rest[1]—the upper elements yearn to ascend upward, namely the Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah,[A] while the lower elements yearn to descend downward, namely the limbs of the body,[2] for "dust it is and to dust it shall return." And the body is the aspect of the male that influences the female, the dust of the earth.[3] When placing him on the ground, they should cover him with a sheet as is customary, to conceal him from the forces of judgment as mentioned above.

ומבחינת איזה רוחות רעות שאינם שולטים אלא על הנראה לעין[iii] ויתחילו ויאמר בית יעקב לכו ונלכה באור ה׳. אל אלהים

And regarding certain evil spirits that only have power over what is visible to the eye, they should begin and say: "O house of Jacob, come and let us walk in the light of the Lord." "God, the

[A] Or: "the celestial components yearn to ascend upward—these being the soul (Nefesh), spirit (Ruach), and higher soul (Neshamah)" — This alternative provides English equivalents alongside the Hebrew terms, making the translation more accessible to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology, while still preserving the technical terms.

[1] This reflects the Neo-Platonic principle that all existence yearns to return to its origin, which was incorporated into Kabbalah. In this context, it explains why the soul ascends while the body descends—each component returns to its cosmic source.

[2] This presents the kabbalistic understanding of human composition as a microcosm of the universe, with 'upper' soul components naturally ascending after death while the 'lower' physical elements return to earth. This understanding informs Jewish burial practices that facilitate this natural cosmic process.

[3] This employs kabbalistic gender symbolism where masculine elements are understood as active/giving and feminine elements as receptive. The body is considered 'masculine' in relation to the 'feminine' earth that receives it, mirroring divine dynamics between masculine and feminine aspects of God.

[i] This expresses a fundamental kabbalistic principle that at death, the components of a person naturally separate according to their spiritual nature: the soul components (Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah) ascend to their spiritual source, while the physical body returns to the earth from which it was formed.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The text extensively draws on Zoharic concepts, particularly regarding the relationship between the human body and divine sefirot, the dynamics of the eye and vision in spiritual realms, and the specific roles of the sefirot Malkhut, Yesod, and Tiferet in death rituals. The mention of 'kelipot' (husks) and the need to subdue them comes directly from Zoharic and Lurianic kabbalistic cosmology. | Cf. Talmud — The author explicitly cites Talmudic sources to justify the practice of placing the deceased on the ground rather than on furniture or vessels that can receive ritual impurity. These references serve to ground mystical practices in halakhic (legal) precedent, demonstrating how Ma'avar Yabok integrates legal and mystical considerations. | Cf. Psalms 115:17 — This biblical quotation is used to explain why one should not direct one's gaze toward the deceased—because the dead are disconnected from active divine praise. In kabbalistic thought, this separation requires careful ritual management to ensure proper spiritual transitions. | Cf. Psalm 33:18 — This biblical verse is used to explain the mystical concept that divine vision (represented by the eyes) remains in the realm of life and divine worship, not in the realm of death. The eyes are connected to divine mercy rather than judgment. | Cf. Psalm 103:19 — This verse is cited to demonstrate that while Malkhut (Kingdom) may extend into the realm of death to subdue negative forces, other divine attributes (particularly those associated with vision and mercy) do not. This establishes a complex kabbalistic understanding of how different divine attributes relate to death.

[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that certain spiritual forces can only affect what is visible, which is why covering the deceased is important for spiritual protection.

ה׳ דיבר ויקרא ארץ ממזרח שמש
עד מבואו. יבא שלום ינוחו על
משכבותם הולך נכחו. כי עפר
אתה ואל עפר תשוב. ויאמר זה
ג׳ פעמים ויכוונו לסוד עפר
העליון שהיא בינה ועפר התחתון
שהיא מלכות[i] ולעפר קברו
למטה ובפרט אם נקבר בארץ
ישראל ואחרי ששמו אותו על
גבי קרקע יאמרו עליו מזמור
לדוד ה׳ רועי עד סופו ושיר של
פגעים בחתוך מלותיו[ii] ובכוונה
גדולה ובפרט פסוק כי מלאכיו
יצוה לך כי הוא מסוגל מאד כמו
שבא למעלה בארוכה במאמר
ב׳ וסופו ד׳ תיבות אלה הם
יו״ך. והוא סוד י״ו פיות שיש
לחרבו של הקב״ה[iii] ובהם הוא
מכה וזהו יו״ך י״ו ה״ך. ולכן
תקנו להנצל מהם י״ו בני אדם
שיעלו לס״ת בשבוע שבעה בשבת
שחרית שלשה במנחה ושלשה

Lord God has spoken and called the earth from the rising of the sun to its setting." "Peace shall come; they shall rest on their beds, each walking in his uprightness." "For dust you are, and to dust you shall return."[1] They should say this three times, and they should focus on the mystery of the supernal dust,[A] which is Binah, and the lower dust, which is Malkhut, and the dust of his grave below, especially if he is to be buried in the Land of Israel. And after they place him on the ground, they should recite over him Psalm 23 ("The Lord is my shepherd") to its conclusion, and the "Song of Afflictions" (Psalm 91) with clear articulation of its words[B] and with great intention, especially the verse "For He shall command His angels concerning you," as it is extremely beneficial, as was explained at length above in Discourse 2. Its ending four words are YO-HAKH, which is the mystery of the sixteen mouths of the Holy One, blessed be He's sword,[2] with which He strikes, and this is YO-HAKH: YO H-KH.[C] Therefore, they instituted, to be saved from them, that sixteen people should

[A] Or: "and they should direct their intention toward the mystery of the supernal dust" — The Hebrew term 'yekavnu' specifically refers to kavvanah (mystical intention), a technical term in Jewish mysticism for directing one's consciousness toward specific spiritual concepts during ritual actions.

[B] Or: "with precise enunciation of its words" — The Hebrew phrase implies a careful, deliberate pronunciation where each word is distinctly separated from the next, as if 'cut' from surrounding words. This alternate translation emphasizes the precision required.

[C] Or: "YO-HAKH is composed of YO [representing the number 16] and HAKH [meaning 'strikes']" — This is a more interpretive translation that explains the wordplay in the Hebrew, where the term is broken down to show both its numerical value (16) and its meaning (strikes/smites).

[1] This is a direct quote from Genesis 3:19, spoken by God to Adam after the sin in Eden. Its recitation here connects the deceased's burial with the primordial human condition and divine decree.

[2] This represents a kabbalistic interpretation where the final words of Psalm 91 are seen as connected to divine judgment. The 'sixteen mouths' of God's sword represent channels of judgment that can be mitigated through proper ritual and Torah study.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic correspondence between dust/earth and divine emanations: the 'supernal dust' corresponds to Binah (Understanding, the third sefirah), while the 'lower dust' corresponds to Malkhut (Kingdom, the tenth sefirah). By focusing on these correspondences, those attending the deceased create spiritual connections between the physical burial and cosmic processes.

[ii] Psalm 91 is traditionally known as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons) and was considered especially effective against harmful spiritual forces. The instruction to recite it 'with clear articulation of its words' emphasizes the belief that precise pronunciation enhances its protective power.

[iii] This references a mystical concept that God's sword of judgment has sixteen 'mouths' or cutting edges, from which punishment emanates. The numerical value of YO-HAKH (יו״ך) is sixteen, creating a connection between the psalm's words and this divine instrument.

בשני ושלשה בחמישי וזהו
שהתחילה התורה בב׳ וסיים בל׳
הם ל״ב ברכות שמברכים ששה
עשר בני אדם העולים לקרות
ברכה ראשונה ואחרונה. ולזה
אפשר שרמזו באמרם ספר תורה
וסייף ירדו כרוכים יחד.[i] העוסק
בזה ינצל מזה: ושומרי המת כבר
הזהרנו שיזהרו עצמם מלשון
הרע וקטטה ומריבה ושבועות
והזכרת שם שמים לבטלה ח״ו
וניבול פה בעודם שם לפחות
וימעטו דבריהם ככל האפשר
שכל המרבה דברים מביא חטא.
במקומות אלו בפרט ומה טוב אם
יבקשו עליו רחמים בשירי דוד
ובמזמורים המסומנים למעלה
וכן חוצבי הקבר והמתעסקים
בארגז ובשאר צרכיו לא יפגמו
לשונם ויזהרו מלחטוא בנפשותם
בזה ושמירת המת הוא כדי שלא
יתעוללו בו המזיקין והרוחות
כנזכר:[iii][ii]

be called up to the Torah during the week: seven on Sabbath morning, three at the afternoon service, three on Monday, and three on Thursday. This is why the Torah begins with the letter Bet and ends with Lamed, which together equal thirty-two, corresponding to the thirty-two blessings that the sixteen people called up to read recite[1] (opening and closing blessings). Perhaps this is what they alluded to when they said, "The Torah scroll and the sword descended from heaven bound together." Whoever engages in this [Torah] will be saved from this [sword]. As for those who guard the deceased, we have already cautioned that they should guard themselves against evil speech, quarreling, disputes, oaths, and mentioning God's name in vain, God forbid, and vulgar language while they are there, at the very least. They should minimize their talk as much as possible, for whoever speaks excessively brings sin, especially in these places. How good it is if they seek mercy for him through the songs of David and the psalms designated above. Likewise, those who dig the grave and those who attend to the coffin and his other needs should not blemish their speech and should be careful not to sin against their souls in this matter. Guarding the deceased is so that harmful spirits and demons do not abuse him,[2] as mentioned.

פרק י׳

Chapter 10

[1] Each person called to the Torah recites two blessings: one before and one after reading. The text connects this practice to cosmic protection, suggesting that these blessings form a spiritual shield.

[2] This clearly states the practical mystical purpose behind the Jewish custom of not leaving the deceased alone before burial. The Hebrew term 'mazzikin' refers specifically to harmful spiritual entities believed to be drawn to the vulnerability of death.

[i] This is a rabbinic saying indicating that Torah study and divine judgment are interconnected—engaging with one (Torah) protects from the other (the sword of judgment).

[ii] This explicitly states the purpose of guarding the deceased before burial: to prevent harmful spirits (mazzikin) from abusing the body. In Jewish mystical thought, the period between death and burial is considered a time when the body is particularly vulnerable to negative spiritual forces.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 91 (Song of Afflictions) — This psalm was traditionally recited to protect the deceased from harmful spiritual entities during the vulnerable period between death and burial. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The text shares the Zohar's concern with protecting both the deceased and mourners from harmful spiritual forces that are believed to be present during the transition between life and death. | Cf. Deuteronomy 31:19 — The mystical significance of the Torah beginning with Bet and ending with Lamed creates the word 'lev' (heart), symbolizing that the Torah's essence is the heart of existence. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) — The text's reference to 32 blessings parallels the kabbalistic structure of the 32 paths of wisdom, suggesting that Torah readings create cosmic protection through these 32 channels.

השופר שהיו נוהגים לתקוע
בעת שהיו נושאים המת לבית
הקברות כתיב בפ׳ ויקהל דף
קצ״ו ב׳ שהיה להגין על החיים
שלא ישלוט בהם מלאך המות
להשטין למעלה דאז איתי ליה
רשותא. והזהיר בכל תוקף לבל
יתראו הנשים עם האנשים בעת
הליכתן לבית הקברות כל שכן
בעת חזרתן שמלאך המות ביניהן
ואמר דבשבע בעי דינא. ובעשרה
אסגי לקטלא. ואמר דכמה בני
אדם מסתלקים מן העולם קודם
זמנן בגין דלא אזדהרין מן דא.
ולכן יש למנוע הנשים מללכת
לבית הקברות עם האנשים. וכל
שכן בחזרתן ובשום פנים לא ילך
בדרך עמה אז. והועד לפני מפי
אדם כשר[i] שכך נתפשט המנהג
בכל ארץ הצבי[ii] ובבבל ובכל
מלכות מזרח שבתחלה הולכים
האנשים ושם עומדים שמשים
ממונים להפריש הנשים שלא
יתחילו לצאת עד אחר שעברו
כל האנשים. ואחר הקבורה
מתעכבים שם הנשים כמו רבע
שעה עד שיצאו כל האנשים ושם
מקוננות על הנפטר. ויש מקומות
שאינן יוצאות אחר המטה כלל.
וגם מדברי הגמ׳ נראה שלא
היו יוצאות עם האנשים דאמרי׳
בפ׳ כ״ג[iii] מקום שנהגו הנשים
לצאת לפני המטה יוצאות
ומקום שנהגו לילך אחר המטה
הולכות. ומפרש בירושלמי
מפני כבודן של בנות ישראל
שלא יסתכלו בהם האנשים הנה
כי חשו בירושלמי להסתכלות

Regarding the shofar that was customarily blown when carrying the deceased to the cemetery, it is written in Parashat Vayakhel, page 196b, that its purpose was to protect the living so that the Angel of Death would not gain power over them to accuse them above,[1] for at that time he has permission to do so. The text strongly warns against men and women being seen together when walking to the cemetery, especially when returning, because the Angel of Death is among them. It states that with seven people he seeks judgment, and with ten he increases killing.[2] It further states that many people depart from the world before their time because they are not careful about this matter. Therefore, women should be prevented from walking to the cemetery with men, and especially from returning with them, and under no circumstances should a man walk with a woman on the road at that time.

I was informed by a reliable person that this custom spread throughout the Holy Land, Babylonia, and throughout the eastern kingdoms, where the men would go first, and officials would stand there to separate the women, who would not begin to leave until after all the men had passed. After the burial, the women would remain there for about a quarter of an hour until all the men had departed, and there they would lament over the deceased. In some places, women would not follow the bier at all.

From the Talmud it also appears that women did not go out with the men, as it states in Chapter 23, "In a place where women customarily go out before the bier, they go out, and in a place where they customarily go after the bier, they go after." The Jerusalem Talmud explains this is for the honor of the daughters of Israel, that men should not look at them. Thus, we see that the Jerusalem Talmud was concerned about men gazing at them, though

5R 10R 15R 20R 25R 30R 35R

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the Angel of Death serves as a prosecutor in the heavenly court, bringing accusations against the living before God.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that larger gatherings during vulnerable times like funerals can intensify the power of the Angel of Death, with specific thresholds at seven and ten people.

[i] The phrase 'from the mouth of a reliable person' indicates that the author is reporting a custom he heard about from someone he considered trustworthy, rather than something he personally witnessed or found in written sources.

[ii] This is a term for the Land of Israel, derived from Daniel 11:16, where the land is described as 'the beautiful land' or 'the land of glory.'

[iii] This refers to chapter 23 of a Talmudic tractate, likely Mo'ed Katan, which discusses laws of mourning.

בהן הגם שפשט דבריו יראה
משום הרגל עבירה יוכל גם כן
לפרש שכוונתו גם למה שאמרו
בזהר וזהו כבודן לבל יגרמו
נזק לעולם ומצאתי קצת סמך
למה הקינה מיוחדת לנשים
כדכתיב ולמדנה בנותיכם נהי
ואשה רעותה קינה. וכן התבוננו
וקראו למקוננות. ובמשנה גם
כן נשים במועד מענות והטעם
מפני שהם מצד הדין ולכן
בבכייתן ודמעתן מכבות אותו
על דרך מה שכתב החכם אלשיך
בפירושו למגילת איכה על סוד
הדמעות עוד מצאתי בפ׳ פקודי
דף רנ״ז ע״ב דאמר כל אינון
דאתיין מסטרא דשמאלא מסטרא
דנוקבא אתמנן על השיר ואמרי
שירתא תדיר וזהו על עלמות
שיר[i] ואולי יהיה כטעם שיר של
הלוים להיותם מצד הדין ולכן
להם לבסמו בשירם ואמרי׳ בפ׳
שמות דף י״ט כי השירים עליונים
עמדו עד שנולד לוי ואז פתחו
בשיר ופי׳ למה נקרחו לויים
בשם זה וכ״ש דמזה נוכל להקיש
בקינות ובכי כי אותם הבאים
ומושפעים תדיר מכח הדינים
יפה כחם לשברם ולהחלישם. על
דרך מיניה וביה אבא ליזיל ביה
נרגא וירך דסטרא אחרא מתוכה
מסרחת ועוד כי מצדם הבכי
והנהי והקינה והם ג׳ מיני יללות
שכן כחות החצונים הם משולשים
כמו שאמר ומבחר שלשיו[ii] כי
יוצאים ויונקים מג׳ קליפות רוח
סערה ענן גדול ואש מתלקחת

the plain meaning of the text suggests it was to prevent sinful thoughts. One could also interpret that the intention aligns with what is said in the Zohar, meaning it was for their honor, so they would not cause harm to the world.

I found some support for why lamentation is specifically associated with women, as it is written, "Teach your daughters wailing, and each woman her neighbor a dirge." Similarly, "Consider and call for the mourning women." The Mishnah also states that "women chant during the festival," and the reason is because they are from the side of judgment,[1] so through their weeping and tears they extinguish it, as explained by the sage Alshich in his commentary on the Book of Lamentations regarding the secret of tears.

I also found in Parashat Pekudei, page 257b, which states that all those who come from the left side, from the feminine aspect, are appointed over song and sing continually, and this is the meaning of "according to alamot [maidens] a song." Perhaps this is similar to the reason for the Levites' song, as they are from the side of judgment, and therefore it is appropriate for them to sweeten it with their song. And we say in Parashat Shemot, page 19, that the celestial songs stood silent until Levi was born, and then they began to sing, and it explains why the Levites were called by this name. All the more so, we can draw a parallel to lamentations and weeping, for those who continually come from and are influenced by the powers of judgment are well-suited to break and weaken them. This follows the principle of "from itself comes the axe handle to fell it,"[2] and the thigh of the Other Side rots from within. Furthermore, from their side comes weeping, wailing, and lamentation, which are three types of howling, because the external forces

[1] In kabbalistic thought, women are associated with the 'left side' or 'feminine aspect' which corresponds to the divine attribute of judgment (gevurah/din) rather than mercy (chesed), explaining their connection to lamentation.

[2] This is a Talmudic proverb meaning that the very thing that causes harm can also be the source of its remedy. In this context, it suggests that since women are associated with judgment, they are particularly effective at mitigating judgment through their tears and lamentations.

[i] This phrase comes from Psalm 46:1, where it may refer to young women singing or to a musical term. The author interprets it kabbalistically to connect women to the concept of song.

[ii] This phrase 'and the choicest of his officers' comes from Exodus 15:4, referring to Pharaoh's officers drowning in the sea. Here it is interpreted kabbalistically to refer to the threefold nature of negative spiritual forces.

כי הרביעית נכללת בקדושה
בנודע: גם מזה נראה כמה צריך
האדם לשמור עצמו מלהזכיר
כחות הקטגוריא בעת הסכנה
רחמנא ליצלן. ועיין בזהר פרשת
נח בסוף דף קי״ג שהזהיר כי אין
להזכיר כחות הטומאה בלילה
עת שליטתן ובמקום שיש תנוקות
בני שנתן בפרט. ונמצא כתוב
כי חסיד אחד הזכיר שם ס״מ
בלילה באמצע דבור עם בני
אדם ובבקר ראה אותו רבו
האר״י זצ״ל[i] וא״ל הרי עברת
בלילה על ושם אלהים אחרים לא
תזכירו ולכן הזהר כל ימיך שלא
תזכור שמו ולא כיוצא בו ובפרט
בלילה כי אז יכול להתגבר
עליך ועל אחרים בסבתך.
וכ״ש שאין להזכירם במקום
שיש מתי ישראל דתיאובתייהו
לשלוט בגופיהון[ii] כדפירשו
בזהר פ׳ אמור דף פ״ח. ועיין
בפרשת נשא דף קכ״ו כמה
דינין מתעוררים על המת אם
מלינים אותו שלא לצורך. בעת
שמזמינים עצמם לטהרו טוב
שהגדול שבהם[iii] יבקש עליו
רחמים בתפלה ותחנה בגין
דיתרבי ויתוסף רבות קדושה
באתר דאצטריך ויכוין לעורר
הרחמים. ועיין בתחלת הספר
מה יביעו וידברו אז: [iv]

are threefold,[1] as it says, “and the choicest of his officers,” for they emerge and draw from three shells: the stormy wind, the great cloud, and the flashing fire,[2] since the fourth is included in holiness, as is known. 80R

From this we can also see how much a person needs to guard against mentioning accusatory forces in times of danger, God forbid. See the Zohar, Parashat Noah, at the end of page 113, which warns against mentioning forces of impurity at night, the time of their dominion, especially in places where there are year-old infants. It is written that a certain pious man once mentioned the name of Samael at night while speaking with people, and in the morning his teacher, the ARI of blessed memory, saw him and said, “You transgressed last night the commandment ‘Do not mention the names of other gods.’ Therefore, be careful all your days not to mention his name or anything similar, especially at night, for then he can gain power over you and over others because of you.” All the more so, one should not mention them in a place where there are deceased Israelites, for their desire is to control their bodies, as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Emor, page 88. See also Parashat Naso, page 126, for how many judgments are aroused against the deceased if they delay the burial unnecessarily. 85R 90R 95R 100R

When preparing to purify the deceased, it is good for the most distinguished among them to ask for mercy through prayer and supplication, so that holiness may increase and be added in the place where it is needed,[3] and he should intend to arouse mercy. 105R

[1] This explains why there are three types of female mourning expressions (weeping, wailing, and lamentation), as they correspond to and counteract the three levels of negative spiritual forces.
[2] These three manifestations are derived from Ezekiel’s vision (Ezekiel 1:4) and in Kabbalah represent three levels of impurity or negative forces. The fourth level mentioned (kelipat nogah or ‘shining shell’) contains a mixture of good and evil and thus ‘is included in holiness.’
[3] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that prayer and proper intention (kavvanah) during ritual

[i] This refers to Rabbi Isaac Luria (1534-1572), known as the ARI, the prominent kabbalist who revolutionized Jewish mysticism in Safed. The story illustrates the caution required when speaking about negative spiritual forces.
[ii] This Aramaic phrase means ‘for their desire is to control their bodies,’ referring to the negative spiritual forces’ desire to gain control over the bodies of the deceased.
[iii] The ‘greatest among them’ refers to the most distinguished or learned member of the burial society (Chevra Kadisha) who is conducting the tahara (ritual purification of the deceased).
[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This passage from the Zohar explains the purpose of blowing the shofar during funeral processions as a protective measure against the Angel of Death, who has special permission to accuse the living during funerals. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Emor — This source discusses how negative spiritual forces desire to control the bodies of the deceased, reinforcing the need for proper burial practices and caution when speaking about these forces in the presence of the dead. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Naso — This reference warns about the negative spiritual conse-

See the beginning of the book for what they should express and say at that time.

פרק י״א

סדר רחיצת המת למטיבי צעד. ראשונה ירחצו שערות הראש כי שערות האדם רומזים להמשכות[i] כמו שלמעלה בסוד שער הראש מתאחדים בהם עליונים ותחתונים[ii] מארי דמארין מארי דקשוט מארי דמתקלא מארי דיבבא מארי דיללא מארי דדינא מארי דרחמי וטעמי אורייתא ורזי אורייתא דכיין ומסאבן כלהו נקרא שערי. פי׳ מטיבותא דאתמשך ממלכא קדישא. ואמרו המשכילים ומביני דעת כי מנין שערות הראש הם אלף אלפי רבואות ושבעת אלפים שערות[iii] ישתבח שמו הכולל כמה אלף אלפים עולמות עד אין תכלית ומספר. וכלם גנוזים ונעלמים לשעשועו. ואין מי שידעם אלא הוא בעצמו האצילם לקיום הנמצאות. ודרך

Chapter 11

The order of washing the deceased for those who tread with care.[A1] First, they should wash the hair of the head, for a person's hair alludes to divine emanations. Just as above, in the mystery of the head's hair, higher and lower realms unite—masters of masters, masters of truth, masters of balance, masters of wailing, masters of lamentation, masters of judgment, masters of mercy, and the reasons of Torah and mysteries of Torah, both pure and impure—all are called "gates," meaning the goodness that flows from the Holy King. 5R 10R

The wise ones and those of understanding have said that the number of hairs on the head equals one million myriads and seven thousand hairs—praised be His name which encompasses thousands upon thousands of worlds without end or number. All these are hidden and concealed for His delight, and none knows them except He Himself who emanated them for the sustenance of all that exists. Generally speaking, there are one million myriads of locks, and in each lock there are four hundred and ten strands, 15R 20R

[A] Or: "those who perform their duty with careful steps" — This alternate translation more explicitly connects the phrase to the Chevra Kadisha members who perform the ritual purification, emphasizing both their careful physical movements and their spiritual mindfulness.

purification of the deceased can channel divine energy to aid the soul's journey and protect it from negative forces.

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'למטיבי צעד' literally means 'for those who improve their steps' and refers to those who perform the ritual washing (tahara) with proper care and reverence.

quences of delaying burial unnecessarily, as it arouses divine judgments against the deceased. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — The Jerusalem Talmud explains that women's procession practices at funerals were arranged to preserve their modesty and honor, preventing men from gazing at them inappropriately. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — This passage connects women's lamentation practices to kabbalistic concepts of the 'left side' and 'feminine aspect' which are associated with judgment, explaining why women's weeping can 'sweeten' or mitigate harsh judgments. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Noah — This source warns against mentioning forces of impurity at night when their power is greatest, particularly in the presence of infants. | Cf. Book of Lamentations — The reference to Alshich's commentary reveals the mystical concept that women's tears have special power to 'extinguish' harsh judgments, connecting mourning practices to kabbalistic cosmology.

[i] The text establishes a kabbalistic framework for the ritual washing of the deceased by connecting each body part to its corresponding divine counterpart. Hair is particularly significant as it represents divine emanations flowing from the supernal realms.

[ii] This references the kabbalistic concept that hair serves as a conduit between higher and lower worlds, where different spiritual forces converge.

[iii] The specific numbers mentioned here have mystical significance in kabbalistic numerology, with each hair representing a distinct spiritual channel.

כלל הם אלף אלפים רבואות
קוצות ובכל קוץ ארבע מאה
ועשר נימין במספר קדוש. ובכל
נימא ארבע מאה ועשר עולמות
במנין קדוש ובכל עולם שבע
מאה ועשרין עובר. שבע מאה
מצד ז׳ ספירות זעיר ועשרין
מצד סופי בחינות חכמה ובינה
הנגלות בשבעה התחתונים.
ועובר הם קצוות ורבוי בחינות.
והקצוות הם נובעות הארת
לובן רחמיו כי תר״ך עמודי
אור שהם בכתר מתפשטים בכל
עולם מלבד כללות אחד ממאה
בכל אחד וזהו שאמר כי העולם
שהוא עולם הנקביי הנעלם להיט
למטה לשבע מאה מצד הנקבה
בת שבע ועשרים כבר אמרנו
שהם בסוד ב׳ בחינות על השבעה
שהם חכמה ובינה ועובר ירצה
בחינות הקצוות והספירות.
ומי הוא שיוכל לשער ולתת
טעם למציאות בחינות רבות
אלו מפני העלמן בעצמן. וכל
אלו הם א׳ מאלף אלפי אלפים
ורבי רבואות מהאוכלוסין
שיש לדרוש בבחינת רישא
עילאה[i] כי אין סוף לגדודיו
וזוהי בחינה אחת לבד מתקון י״ג
תקוני דיקנא שהמתקת ובבישת
הדינים תלוי בו. זה כתבתי דרך
העברה להודיע כמה יש לדרוש
אפי׳ בבחינת השער[ii] שהוא
התפשטות לבר מגופא כ״ש בסוד

corresponding to the numerical value of "holy."[1] In each strand there are four hundred and ten worlds, also corresponding to "holy," and in each world there are seven hundred and twenty aspects—seven hundred from the seven lower sefirot and twenty from the final aspects of Wisdom and Understanding as they are revealed in the seven lower ones. These aspects are extremities and multiple dimensions, and these extremities flow from the illumination of the whiteness of His mercy, for the 620 pillars of light in Keter[2] extend into every world, besides the general inclusion of one in a hundred in each one. This is what is meant when it says that the world, which is the hidden feminine world, flames downward to seven hundred from the feminine aspect of seven and twenty. We have already said that these are in the mystery of the two aspects upon the seven,[3] which are Wisdom and Understanding, and "aspects" refers to the extremities and sefirot.

Who can measure and give reason for the existence of these many aspects, due to their inherent concealment? All these are but one of thousands upon thousands and myriads upon myriads of multitudes that can be expounded regarding the aspect of the Supernal Head, for His legions are without end. And this is just one aspect apart from the thirteenth configuration of the holy beard,[4] upon which depends the sweetening and subduing of judgments.[A] I have written this in passing to inform how much there is to expound even in the aspect of hair, which is an extension outside the body, how much more so regarding the mystery of the essence.

The aspect of the forehead alludes to the Supernal Forehead, which visits the wicked when their sins

[A] Or: "mitigating and conquering harsh judgments" — This alternate might be clearer for readers less familiar with kabbalistic terminology, where 'sweetening' is a technical term for transforming judgment into mercy.

[1] The Hebrew word for 'holy' (קדוש) has the numerical value of 410 in gematria (Hebrew numerology).

[2] The number 620 (תר״ך) corresponds to the numerical value of 'crown' (כתר) in Hebrew, representing the highest divine emanation.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the two higher intellectual sefirot (Wisdom/Chokhmah and Understanding/Binah) influencing the seven lower, more emotional sefirot.

[4] In Kabbalah, particularly in the Idra texts of the Zohar, the divine 'beard' has thirteen distinct configurations (tikkunim) that channel divine mercy to counteract judgment.

[i] The author emphasizes the vastness and incomprehensibility of divine structures, of which human understanding can grasp only a tiny fraction.

[ii] The author acknowledges that this extended discussion of mystical hair symbolism is merely introductory, suggesting the even greater mysteries of other bodily correspondences.

העצמות. בחינת המצח רומזות
למצח העליון שהיא פוקדת
הרשעים בשמתגלה עונותם
למעלה ומצחא ירצה גבורה
אתתקף בדינוהי ואתפשט וצריך
תקון ומתוק. בחינת העינים
תרמוז להשגחת הכל עליונים
ותחתונים. בחינת גביני העינים
הוא מקום שמשם באה ההשגחה
לכל בעלי ההשגחה וממשיכים
מנהר דנפיק ונגיד לרחוץ כח
הגבורה שהיא המצח בחלב עליון
הה״ד רוחצות בחלב. בחינת
החוטם רמז לדינים שנתעוררו
המתבסמים בעשן המזבח. בחינת
האזנים הוא כשהרצון נמצא ואור
עליון מעורר אור אבא ואמא
בחינת המוחין ואז מתקבלת
תפלתן של ישראל ובהתעוררות
הזה מתעוררים בעלי כנפים
הנוטלים הקולות הנקרא אזני
ה׳. בחינת הפנים הוא אור
אבא ואימא המתפשט בראש
המלך. בחינת הדיוקן הוא כשכל
המאורות עליונות נכללות יחד
נקראים כן. בחינת שפתים ופה
הם אורות אבא ואמא ודעת
ביניהם ואז יוצא בחינת המלות
בחכמה בתבונה ובדעת ובחינה
פנימית מהג׳ אלה נקראים חיך
שבו השלימות מתראה באותיות
אח״הע. בחינת גופא הוא
התפשטות תפארת שכל הגוונים
מתחברים בו בחינת זרועות
הם אורות חסד וגבורה. בחינת
המעים דעת בפנימיותו. בחינת
השוקים והכליות כלם רומזים
למקום אחד שהם נ״ה ושם נמשך
כל כח ומדת הגוף ומשם מריקות
הכל לאבר הקדוש שהוא שלום

are revealed above. The forehead represents Gevurah (Strength) strengthened in its judgments and extended, requiring rectification and sweetening. The aspect of the eyes alludes to the providence over all, both above and below. The aspect of the eyebrows is 60R
the place from which providence comes to all those subject to providence, drawing from the river that emerges and flows to wash the power of Gevurah, which is the forehead, in supernal milk, as it is written, "washed with milk." The aspect of the nose 65R
alludes to aroused judgments that are sweetened by the smoke of the altar. The aspect of the ears is when the will is present and supernal light awakens the light of Father and Mother, the aspect of the intellect, and then the prayers of Israel are ac- 70R
cepted. Through this awakening, the winged beings who carry the sounds called "the ears of the Lord" are aroused. The aspect of the face is the light of Father and Mother extending in the head of the King. The aspect of the countenance is when all the super- 75R
nal luminaries are included together, they are called thus. The aspect of lips and mouth are the lights of Father and Mother with Knowledge between them, and then the aspect of words emerges in Wisdom, Understanding, and Knowledge. The inner aspect of 80R
these three is called the palate, wherein completeness is revealed through the letters alef, chet, hei, and ayin.[1] The aspect of the body is the extension of Tiferet (Beauty), where all colors combine. The aspect of the arms represents the lights of Chesed 85R
(Kindness) and Gevurah (Strength). The aspect of the intestines is Knowledge in its inwardness. The aspect of the thighs and kidneys all allude to one place, which is Netzach and Hod, and there all the power and measure of the body flows, and from there ev- 90R
erything pours to the holy organ, which is the peace of the house.[A2] Netzach and Hod are named "Lord of Hosts" and "God of Hosts." All these configurations unite together until all the holy abundance is taken by Yesod and poured into his accompanying 95R

[A] Or: "foundation of domestic harmony" — This alternative makes the euphemistic nature of the reference more explicit while preserving the connection to its kabbalistic correlation with the divine attribute of Yesod (Foundation).

[1] These four letters (אח״הע) are guttural consonants in Hebrew that are formed in the palate/throat, thus connecting Hebrew linguistics with mystical anatomy.

[2] This is a euphemistic reference to the reproductive organ, called 'peace of the house' (שלום הבית) because of its role in marital harmony. In Kabbalah, it corresponds to the divine attribute of Yesod (Foundation).

הבית ונ״ה ה׳ צבאות ואלהים
צבאות שמם. וכל תקונים אלו
מתחברים יחד עד שכל רבות
קדשא נטיל יסוד ומריק בלויה
100 שלו מלכות ומתברכת ממנו.
וזהו בעת שלמטה מתקנים
הדינין ובצדק ישפוטו דאז כל
תקונין דמלכא בחדוותא בשלימו
דכתיב אלהים נצב בעדת אל.
105 המעלה על לבו בחינות אלו
עם פסוקי שיר השירים שאמרנו
בעת רחיצת אדם גדול[i] שקדש
גופו בעה״ז ונזהר מכל טומאה
כפי האפשר בזמננו זה ברחוץ
110 תשמישי קדושה אלו ויקביל
בחינות רוחניות כחות קדושים
אלו לעומתן אדם זה ביקר
ילין וישמח ויגל מאד באדם
הזה החי באמת המחיה ונותן
115 נשמה ברוחניותו לאבריו המתים
מכח ההרגשה טבעית אך לא
מהרוחניות כדאמרו בפ׳ שואל
כל שאומרים בפני המת יודע עד
שיסתם הגולל[ii] והנה הגומל עמו
120 חסדים טובים בהשים בקרבו את
רוח קדשו שהעיר וקשט בעשותו
פה למטה ודאי במלאכת שמים
זו יזכה לו ולבניו. הרי שאברי
האדם כלם נרמזים למעלה
125 ולא להם חלק בגשמיות כי
בתוכם האלהות הקדוש נסתר
ונגלה והסתרת נפש האדם בגוף
כהסתרת מדה אחת במה שלמטה
ממנה בספירות עליונות אשרי
130 המקדש עצמו בעה״ז.[iii] ויזהר

Malkhut, which is blessed by it. This occurs when those below rectify judgments and judge with righteousness, for then all the configurations of the King are in joy and completeness, as it is written, "God stands in the divine assembly." 100R

One who takes to heart these aspects, along with the verses from Song of Songs that we mentioned during the washing of a distinguished person[A] who sanctified his body in this world and was careful to avoid all impurity as much as possible in our time, by 105R washing these holy implements and receiving these spiritual aspects and holy powers corresponding to them—such a person will abide in honor and rejoice greatly in this person who truly lives, who gives life and soul in his spirituality to his limbs that are dead 110R through natural sensation but not through spirituality. As they said in chapter "One Who Asks," everything said in the presence of the deceased, he knows until the grave is sealed.[1] Behold, the one who bestows good kindnesses upon him by placing 115R within him his holy spirit, which he awakened and adorned by his actions here below, will surely merit this heavenly work for himself and his children.

Thus, all the limbs of a person are alluded to above, and they have no share in materiality, for 120R within them the holy divinity is both hidden and revealed. The concealment of a person's soul in the body is like the concealment of one attribute within what is below it in the supernal sefir[2]ot. Fortunate is one who sanctifies himself in this world. A per- 125R son should be careful while still alive to avoid anything associated with impurity, even in the words of the Sages, such as removing one's shoes, touching one's body, or washing one's head, and all the things mentioned, and those things associated with 130R

[A] Or: "a great man" — The more literal 'great man' might better preserve the term's connotation of spiritual greatness rather than merely social distinction, though both meanings are present in the Hebrew.

[1] This refers to the Talmudic teaching that the deceased maintains awareness until the burial is complete, which is why proper respect and careful ritual treatment are essential.

[2] This describes the kabbalistic concept of each higher divine attribute (sefirah) being 'clothed' or concealed within the lower attribute, just as the soul is concealed within the body.

[i] This indicates that verses from Song of Songs were recited during the ritual washing of distinguished individuals, with specific verses likely corresponding to different body parts.

[ii] This references a Talmudic teaching that the deceased remains aware of what is happening around them until burial is complete, which adds spiritual significance to the purification ritual.

[iii] The text transitions from mystical cosmology to practical moral exhortation, suggesting that understanding these correspondences should motivate proper conduct in life.

האדם בעוד בחיים חיותו מכל
דבר הנזכר בו טומאה[i] ואפי׳
בדברי חכמים כגון החולץ
מנעליו והנוגע בגופו והחופף
בראשו וכל הדברים שנזכרו
ומהדברים שנזכר בהם טומאה
ונדוי בדברי חכמינו ז״ל.
ובפרט לא ילך ד״א בבקר בלא
נטילת ידים[ii] כי דברים אלו
גורמים טומאה לנשמתו בצאתה
מן הגוף ומתאמצים בה הרוחות
רעות שהחזיקו בו בחיים ואז
מבקשים שלהם מתחת ידו ושומר
נפשו ירחק מהם. ואל יהא קל
בעיניו שום אזהרה הנזכרת
בדברי חכמים כי הם בחנו וידעו
הדברים על בריין. והמקדש
עצמו קדוש יאמר לו בשעת
מיתתו כדכתיב והתקדשתם
והייתם קדושים. ואמרו דכל מאן
דינטר ארחי אורייתא ואשתדל
בה כמאן דאשתדל בשמא קדישא
שמא עילאה שמא דכליל כל
שמהן ובעובדא תליא מילתא
בעובדא דלתתא לאתערא
לעילא כנזכר למעלה: [iii]

impurity and excommunication in the words of our Sages of blessed memory. In particular, one should not walk four cubits in the morning without washing one's hands, for these things cause impurity to one's soul when it departs from the body, and the evil spirits that took hold of him in life then strengthen in it, demanding what is theirs from under his hand. One who guards his soul will distance himself from them. No warning mentioned in the words of the Sages should be taken lightly, for they examined and knew these matters thoroughly. One who sanctifies himself will be called holy at the time of his death, as it is written, "You shall sanctify yourselves and be holy." And they said that whoever guards the ways of Torah and engages in it is like one who engages with the holy Name, the supernal Name that includes all names, and the matter depends on action—on action below to awaken above,[1] as mentioned above.

[1] This expresses a fundamental kabbalistic principle that human actions in the physical realms have corresponding effects in the spiritual realms, particularly when performed with proper intention (kavvanah).

[i] This section warns that ritual impurities during life affect the soul after death, suggesting that the tahara (purification) ritual can only partially compensate for a life of impurity.

[ii] Walking four cubits in the morning without ritual hand washing was considered particularly problematic, as it was believed to give evil spirits a hold on the person that could affect their soul even after death.

[iii] Cf. Song of Songs — The text mentions that verses from Song of Songs were recited during the ritual washing of a distinguished person. In kabbalistic tradition, Song of Songs is interpreted as an allegory of the love between God and Israel, and its verses were often incorporated into purification rituals with specific verses corresponding to different body parts. | Cf. Zohar, Idra Rabba — The text's detailed discussion of the 'thirteenth configuration of the holy beard' (תקון י״ג תקוני דיקנא) directly references the Zohar's elaborate discourse on the thirteen attributes of divine mercy as manifested in the metaphorical 'beard' of God, particularly found in the Idra Rabba section. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud — The phrase 'everything said in the presence of the deceased, he knows until the grave is sealed' (כל שאומרים בפני המת יודע עד שיסתם הגולל) is a direct reference to a Talmudic teaching that informs the respectful conduct required during funeral preparations. | Cf. Leviticus 11:44 — The phrase 'והתקדשתם והייתם קדושים' ('You shall sanctify yourselves and be holy') is a direct quotation from Leviticus, used here to emphasize that those who maintain ritual purity in life will be designated as holy at the time of death. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 8:5 — The phrase 'שומר נפשו' ('one who guards his soul') echoes similar phrasing in Ecclesiastes, adapted here to emphasize the spiritual self-protection that comes from observing ritual purity laws. | Cf. Psalms 82:1 — The phrase 'אלהים נצב בעדת אל' ('God stands in the divine assembly') is a direct quotation from Psalms, used here to emphasize divine presence when judgments are properly executed below.

פרק י״ב

בעת שמסירין הסדין מעל המת
לרחצו יכוונו להפשיט ולדחות
מעליו כחות סטרא אחרא דשליט
עליה במיתתו ע״י דההוא מחבלא
דנבל שמיה.[i] ולכן מתי ישראל
שבח״ל נקראי׳ נבלה[ii] כדדרשו
בספר הזהר פ׳ תרומה דף קכ״א
על פסוק יחיו מתיך וגו׳ וצריך
חזוק גדול נגד הפכו למתי חוצה
לארץ שאינם בחיק אמם כי אין
רוחם נכנס למקום מנוחתו מפני
כחות הטומאה המעכבים אותו.
אמנם בארץ הנבחרת אין שם
כחות אחרות כי היא חלק ה׳
ומיד תמצא מנוח לכף רגלה
אם לא יעכבוה עונותיה.[iii] ע״כ
בח״ל צריך תמיד התעוררות
בפסוקי דרחמי. ובמים שרוחצים
אותו בהם[iv] ובפרט ברחיצה
שניה כי הראשונה תהיה להבריח
הרוחות ששורים על הזוהמא
אבל בשניה יכוונו להשפעת
מי החסד עליו הזועם בכל יום
נגד הקליפות והמים נמשכים
דרך קו האמצעי ומריקים עליו
מכלי עליון הברוך ומבורך
ולכן מברכים על המים שהכל
נהיה בדברו על דרך שנאמר

When removing the sheet from the deceased before washing, one should intend to strip away and repel the forces of the Other Side[1] that dominate the deceased at death through the destroyer whose name is Naval[2] (vile). This is why the Jewish dead outside the Land of Israel are called "nevalah" (carcass), as expounded in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 121, on the verse "Your dead shall live..." (Isaiah 26:19). Great spiritual strengthening is needed to counteract these forces for those who die outside the Land of Israel, who are not in their mother's bosom, since their spirits cannot enter their resting place due to the impure forces that obstruct them. However, in the Chosen Land, no such foreign forces exist, for it is the Lord's portion, and immediately the soul finds rest for the sole of its foot, unless its sins prevent it. Therefore, outside the Land of Israel, one always needs spiritual awakening through verses of mercy.

Regarding the water used for washing the deceased, especially during the second washing—for the first washing is to drive away the spirits that dwell on the impurity—during the second washing, one should intend to draw down the waters of loving-kindness upon the deceased, which rage daily against the negative forces. These waters are drawn through the central column[3] and pour upon the deceased from the blessed and exalted supernal vessel. This is why we bless water with "through Whose word ev-

[1] The Hebrew term 'sitra achra' literally means 'the other side' and refers to forces of impurity or evil in kabbalistic thought. These forces are believed to attach themselves to the deceased at the moment of death.

[2] There's a play on words here connecting the name 'Naval' (vile) with 'nevalah' (carcass), suggesting that those who die outside Israel are more susceptible to this destructive spiritual force.

[3] In Kabbalah, the 'central column' refers to the middle line of the sefirot (divine emanations) that balances mercy and judgment. Water, which is used in purification, is associated with this balancing force.

[i] The text refers to the Angel of Death or destructive force as 'Naval' (meaning vile or disgraceful), creating a wordplay that connects to the term 'nevalah' (carcass) used for those who die outside the Land of Israel.

[ii] This striking statement that 'the Jewish dead outside the Land of Israel are called nevalah (carcass)' comes from the Zohar and reflects the spiritual hierarchy that places burial in the Land of Israel as spiritually superior. The text explains that this is not a derogatory term but rather describes the additional spiritual obstacles faced by those buried outside Israel.

[iii] The text acknowledges that even burial in the Land of Israel cannot overcome the spiritual obstacles created by one's sins, suggesting that moral conduct in life remains paramount regardless of burial location.

[iv] The washing ritual is given a detailed mystical interpretation that transforms it from a mere physical cleansing into a cosmic act that draws divine mercy through the 'waters of loving-kindness' to counteract negative spiritual forces.

עולם חסד יבנה והטומאה
באה מן האש מדה השמאלית
ומהרה מן המים אשר במעלה
שביעית[i] והמים נקרא שערי
דמעה שלא ננעלו ושמם כן בזמן
הגלות שבו נאמר השיב אחור
ימינו. והשושנים הנוהגים לרחצו
בהם אינון השפעת המלכות
שהיא שושנה בין החוחים והיא
בתליסר עלין ויתיבת על חמש
עלין תקיפין[ii] ושאר מיני בשמים
שמצרפים עמהם הם להעלאת
נשמתו עד מקום הבינה ולכן
יש מוסיפין ההדס ליחד עליו
כח החסד והדין והרחמים
שלשתן עבותים וכלולים זה
בזה[iii] ולעורר עליו זכות
אבות העולם. ומיני בשמים
בכל מקום רומזים ומעוררים
המקורות למעלה מעלה וראיה
מהקטרת וכן כתיב שמן שהוא
חכמה וקטרת שהוא בינה ישמח
לב.[iv] וכבר דברנו למעלה מסוד
האזוב כי טוב לצרפו עם זינים
אלו כנזכר שם. ובהסרת הסדין
מעליו יענו ויאמרו פסוק ויען
ויאמר אל העומדים לפניו לאמר
וגו׳. ויכוונו במעשיהם ובדבורם

erything came to be," as it is said, "The world is built on loving-kindness" (Psalms 89:3). Impurity comes from fire, the left-side attribute, while purification comes from water, which is of the seventh level, and water is called "the gates of tears" that are never close[1]d, named so during the exile, about which it is said, "He has drawn back His right hand" (Lamentations 2:3).

The roses customarily used to wash the deceased represent the influence of Malkhut (Kingdom), which is like a rose among thorns,[2] with thirteen petals resting upon five strong leaves.[3] The other types of spices combined with these help elevate the soul to the realm of Binah[4] (Understanding). For this reason, some add myrtle to unify over the deceased the powers of loving-kindness, judgment, and mercy—all three intertwined and included within each other—and to awaken the merit of the Patriarchs[5] on their behalf. Spices in every context allude to and awaken the sources on high, as evidenced by the incense offering. Thus it is written, "Oil, which is Wisdom, and incense, which is Understanding, gladden the heart" (Proverbs 27:9). We have already discussed above the mystery of hyssop, which is good to combine with these types as mentioned there.

When removing the sheet from the deceased, they should respond and recite the verse: "And he answered and said to those standing before him, say-

[1]This is a reference to a rabbinic saying that while all gates of prayer may sometimes be closed, the gates of tears are never closed, meaning that sincere tearful prayer is always accepted by God.
[2]This description of Malkhut (the Divine Presence) as a 'rose among thorns' comes from the Zohar and is a fundamental image in Kabbalah, representing divine beauty and vulnerability surrounded by harsh forces.
[3]The thirteen petals represent the thirteen attributes of divine mercy, while the five leaves represent the five powers of judgment (gevurot). This kabbalistic symbolism shows how mercy and judgment are balanced in the divine realm.
[4]In Kabbalah, Binah (Understanding) is one of the highest divine emanations and is associated with the World to Come. The ritual aims to help the soul ascend to this elevated spiritual level.
[5]The concept of 'merit of the Patriarchs' (zechut avot) refers to the spiritual protection and blessing that descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob can access through their ancestral connection.

[i]The reference to water being 'of the seventh level' connects to kabbalistic cosmology where the seventh sefirah (Malkhut) is associated with purification and transition.
[ii]This is a direct reference to the Zohar's symbolic description of Malkhut (the Divine Presence or Shekhinah) as a rose with thirteen petals representing the thirteen attributes of mercy, resting on five strong leaves representing the five gevurot (powers of judgment).
[iii]The three divine attributes (loving-kindness, judgment, and mercy) being 'intertwined' refers to the kabbalistic concept that these seemingly opposing forces are actually interdependent and ultimately unified in the divine realm.
[iv]The text interprets Proverbs 27:9 kabbalistically, identifying oil with Chokhmah (Wisdom) and incense with Binah (Understanding), two of the highest divine emanations in kabbalistic thought.

לתקון נשמתו למעלה[i] ולזה יהיה
מגמת פניהם בעשיית כל צרכיו
כנתבאר למעלה: בשעת הרחיצה
60 בשזורקין מים על ראשו. יאמרו
מעין גנים באר מים חיים ונוזלים
מן לבנון. אם רחץ ה׳ וגו׳.
וזרקתי עליכם מים טהורים
וגו׳. אח״כ יאמרו מקוה ישראל
65 ה׳ וגו׳. והתקדשתם והייתם
קדושים. ואפי׳ לפי פשטי
הכתובים מתבאר כוונתם בזה
כ״ש למי שיעמיק בסוד כל אחד
מהם וכבר עלה בדעתנו לפרש
70 בהם איזה רמזים אך יתארכו
הדרושים[ii] וכבר הרחבנו למעלה
יותר ממה שהיה במחשבתנו הגם
כי השמטנו הרבה פסוקים
ומשניות ומאמרי חכמינו ז״ל
75 שהיו מפרשים ומוסיפים כח
להרבה דברים שדרשנו כפי
עניות דעתנו. הבצים שחופפים
על ראשו[iii] אולי יהיה להסתיר
בחות הדינים הנרמזים בשערות
80 הראש למען יגולו רחמיו על
מדותיו ויחדו יהיו תמים להניח
ברכות על ראשו ויבוסמו
הד׳ מאות בתי דינין דאינון
במצחא בסוד ארבע מאות איש
85 עמו.[iv] וכתיב באדרת האזינו
כי מוצא מארי דיבבא ויללא
ומארי דמארין כלם בשערי זעיר
אנפין וצדיק התחתון בדמותו
נוצר ונברא ועליו נאמר ואיש
90 כי ימרט ראשו קרח הוא טהור

ing..." (Zechariah 3:4). They should direct their actions and speech toward rectifying the soul above, and this should be their intention in performing all necessary preparations, as explained above. 60R

During the washing, when water is sprinkled on the head, they should say: "A garden spring, a well of living waters, flowing from Lebanon" (Song of Songs 4:15); "When the Lord has washed away..." (Isaiah 4:4); "I will sprinkle clean water upon you..." (Ezekiel 36:25). Afterwards, they should say: "O Lord, the hope of Israel..." (Jeremiah 17:13); "Sanctify yourselves and be holy" (Leviticus 20:7). Even according to the plain meaning of these verses, their intention is clear, all the more so for one who delves into the mystery of each verse. I had considered explaining some of these allusions, but the explanations would be lengthy, and I have already elaborated above more than I initially intended, although I have omitted many verses, Mishnaic passages, and sayings of our Sages of blessed memory that would have expounded upon and strengthened many of the matters I have discussed according to my limited understanding. 65R 70R 75R

The eggs that are rubbed on the head of the deceased perhaps serve to conceal the forces of judgment alluded to in the hair of the head, so that His mercies may prevail over His attributes, and together they may be perfect, placing blessings upon the head, sweetening the four hundred houses of judgment[1] that are in the forehead, corresponding to "four hundred men with him" (Genesis 33:1). It is written in the Idra of Ha'azinu (section of the Zohar) that the sources of wailing and lamentation and the masters of masters are all in the hair of Zeir 80R 85R 90R

[1] In kabbalistic literature, these represent comprehensive systems of divine judgment that examine all aspects of human conduct. The egg ritual is meant to mitigate these judgments for the deceased.

[i] This instruction highlights the central kabbalistic principle that physical actions and speech in this world, when performed with proper intention (kavvanah), create corresponding effects in higher spiritual realms.

[ii] The author shows scholarly restraint, acknowledging that while deeper mystical interpretations of these verses are possible, they would make the text too lengthy. This suggests that Ma'avar Yabok was intended to be both practically useful and spiritually profound without becoming overly academic.

[iii] The practice of rubbing eggs on the deceased's head is given a mystical interpretation related to mitigating divine judgment. Eggs were commonly used in purification rituals across various Jewish communities.

[iv] This connects the 'four hundred houses of judgment' from Kabbalistic literature with the biblical story of Esau approaching Jacob with four hundred men (Genesis 33:1), interpreting the latter as an allusion to forces of judgment.

הוא.[i] עוד ביצה ירמוז השפעת כחות המלכות עליו כי ביצה ירמוז לכל ספירה מצד המלכות בסוד אור החוזר בתקונים.[ii] או ליו״ד שבשם בן ד׳ שבחכמה בר״מ. המאיר לכל בסוד כלם בחכמה עשית[iii] ומשם משך שמן הטוב היורד על הראש וכבר דברנו מזה למעלה:[iv]

Anpin (the Lesser Countenance),[1] and the earthly righteous one is formed and created in its image, and of him it is said, "If a man's hair falls out from his head, he is bald; he is clean" (Leviticus 13:40). Additionally, the egg symbolizes the influence of the powers of Malkhut upon him, for an egg alludes to each sefirah from the perspective of Malkhut, in the mystery of reflected light[2] as explained in the Tikkunim. Or it represents the yod in the four-letter Name associated with Wisdom in Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd), which illuminates all in the mystery of "You have made them all with wisdom"[3] (Psalms 104:24), and from there flows the good oil that descends upon the head, as we have discussed above.

פרק י״ג

Chapter 13

אחר הרחיצה כשמלבישים אותו יכוונו לתקון ג׳ מיני מלבושים לנפש רוח ונשמה[v] כפי

After the washing, when dressing him, they should intend to prepare three types of garments for the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah [three levels of the

[1] This is a complex kabbalistic term referring to the six sefirot from Chesed to Yesod that constitute the 'body' of the divine configuration, often associated with the revealed aspects of God that interact with creation.

[2] In Kabbalah, 'or chozer' (reflected light) refers to how divine energy returns upward after descending, creating a reciprocal flow between higher and lower spiritual realms. The egg symbolizes this circular dynamic.

[3] This verse from Psalms is interpreted kabbalistically to mean that Chokhmah (Wisdom) is the divine attribute through which all creation is sustained and illuminated.

[i] The text creatively interprets Leviticus 13:40 (about baldness being ritually clean) in a mystical context related to the deceased being purified and freed from the judgments associated with hair.

[ii] The reference to 'or chozer' (reflected light) in the Tikkunim (Tikkunei Zohar) refers to the kabbalistic concept where lower emanations reflect back the divine light they receive from higher sources, creating a reciprocal spiritual dynamic.

[iii] This quote from Psalm 104:24 ('In wisdom You have made them all') is interpreted kabbalistically to refer to how the divine attribute of Wisdom (Chokhmah) illuminates and sustains all creation.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 121 — The Zohar distinguishes between those who die in the Land of Israel versus those who die outside it, with the latter facing greater spiritual obstacles. This reference supports the ritual washing practices described in the text. | Cf. Idra of Ha'azinu — This section of the Zohar connects the symbolism of hair to divine judgment and the spiritual structure of Zeir Anpin (the Lesser Countenance). The text draws on this to explain why eggs are rubbed on the deceased's head during purification. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — This reference connects the symbolism of the egg to the letter yod of the divine name and to the sefirah of Wisdom (Chokhmah), explaining the mystical significance of using eggs in the purification ritual. | Cf. Tikkunim — The reference to 'Tikkunim' invokes the kabbalistic concept of 'or chozer' (reflected light) in Tikkunei Zohar, explaining how the egg symbolizes Malkhut's reflection of higher sefirot. | Cf. Zechariah 3:4 — This verse is recited when removing the sheet from the deceased, creating a parallel between Joshua the High Priest being purified in Zechariah's vision and the purification of the deceased. The full verse (not quoted completely in the text) continues with 'See, I have removed your iniquity from you, and I will clothe you in pure garments.'

[v] The text refers to the three primary levels of the soul in Jewish mysticism: nefesh (the most basic life force), ruach (the emotional or middle soul), and neshamah (the highest spiritual aspect). According to kabbalistic tradition, each requires its own spiritual 'garment' after death.

המתבאר באדרא בזהר פ׳ ויחי דף רכ״ד ובלבישת הלבוש תחתון והבתי שוקים יכוונו להלביש הנפש.[i] ובסרגני״ז יכוונו להלביש הרוח. ואם נהג ללובשו בחייו ביום הכפורים נ״ל שטוב להבדיל במוצאי יום הכפורים קודם שיפשטנו מעליו[ii] והיודע סוד ההבדלה ורמז יינה יבוסם לו דעת זה.[iii] ובעטיפת הטלית עליו יכוונו להלביש הנשמה[iv] ואם בחייו היה מקיים עטיפתו על ראשו לפחות בתפלת העמידה שחרית טוב להשימו על ראשו ויקשרו אחד מציציותיו אם מנהג המקום כן. אבל לא יפסלו אותו בהסרת הציצית ויכוונו בהנחת הטלית להסתיר אותו מבעלי הדין ולהכניס נשמתו תחת כנפי השכינה.[v] ובשאדם

soul],[1] as explained in the Idra section of the Zohar,[2] Parashat Vayechi, page 224. When dressing him in the undergarment and leggings, they should intend to clothe the nefesh.[3] With the shroud, they should intend to clothe the ruach. And if he was accustomed to wearing it during his lifetime on Yom Kippur, it seems to me that it is good to perform Havdalah at the conclusion of Yom Kippur before removing it from him. One who knows the secret of Havdalah and the symbolism of its wine will find this knowledge fragrant.[4] When wrapping the tallit around him, they should intend to clothe the neshamah. And if during his lifetime he maintained the practice of covering his head with it, at least during the morning Amidah prayer, it is good to place it on his head, and they should tie one of its tzitzit [ritual fringes] if that is the local custom. But they should not invalidate it by removing the tzitzit, and they should intend when placing the tallit to hide him from the forces of judgment and to bring his soul under the wings of the Divine Presence.[5]

5R 10R 15R 20R

[1] Jewish mysticism recognizes multiple levels of the soul, with nefesh, ruach, and neshamah being the three primary ones. The nefesh is the most basic life force associated with physical existence, the ruach is the emotional or middle soul, and the neshamah is the highest spiritual aspect connected to divine intelligence.

[2] The Idra (meaning 'threshing floor' or 'assembly') sections of the Zohar are especially sacred and esoteric portions that purportedly record mystical gatherings led by Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, where the deepest secrets of Kabbalah were revealed.

[3] This passage establishes a correspondence between specific burial garments and components of the soul, reflecting the kabbalistic principle that physical actions create parallel spiritual effects. The lowest garments clothe the lowest soul level (nefesh), while higher garments correspond to higher soul aspects.

[4] This is a deliberately cryptic reference to kabbalistic secrets. In Jewish mysticism, wine in the Havdalah ceremony symbolizes joy and the flow of divine blessing. The author suggests that those initiated into deeper mystical knowledge will understand additional significance to this practice.

[5] The metaphor of divine protection as being 'under the wings of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence)' appears throughout Jewish literature, derived from imagery in Psalms and Ruth. In burial context, it refers to ensuring the soul's peaceful transition to the afterlife under divine protection.

[i] The text establishes a correspondence between specific burial garments and the soul components they are meant to clothe. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that physical actions in this world create parallel spiritual effects.

[ii] This suggests that if a person died while wearing the special white garment (kittel) worn on Yom Kippur, one should perform Havdalah (the ritual marking the end of Yom Kippur) before removing it from the deceased. This demonstrates how Jewish law considers ritual timing even in death circumstances.

[iii] This cryptic phrase suggests there are kabbalistic secrets related to the Havdalah ritual and its wine that would make this practice more meaningful to those with esoteric knowledge.

[iv] The tallit (prayer shawl) is associated with the neshamah, the highest level of the soul, suggesting its special spiritual significance. In burial customs, the tallit is often modified by removing one of the tzitzit (ritual fringes) or by otherwise invalidating it.

[v] This reveals the protective purpose of the tallit in burial—to shield the deceased from negative spiritual forces ('forces of judgment') and to bring the soul under divine protection, metaphorically described as 'the wings of the Divine Presence.'

בחייו מעוטף בציצית ויוצא
לפתח ביתו קב״ה כ״י שמח
ומלאך המות יזוז משם וינצל
האדם מכל היזק ומשחית והיינו
לדורותם לדור אתם. ומזוזת הם
אותיות ז״ז מו״ת.[i] ור׳ נהוראי
פתח אסהדנא על מה דנפיק
בעטיפא דמצוה ותפלין ברישיה
בשעתא דנפיק בין תרין תרעין
אז שבינתא עלויה ותרין מלאכין
קיימין עלוהי חד מימינא וחד
משמאלא ומלוין יתיה עד בי
כנישתא. עוד במנחות פרק
התכלת ראב״י אומר כל שיש לו
תפלין בראשו ותפלין בזרועו
ומזוזה בפתחו וציצית בבגדו
מוחזק שלא יחטא שנאמר והחוט
המשולש וגו׳ ואומר חונה מלאך
ה׳ וגו׳. והטעם הוא כי בר״מ
איתא וכן בתקונים כי שם שדי
הוא שד י׳[ii] ופי׳ שהיו״ד היא
חניקא כריכא בצואריה דשד
שתופס בו ואינו יכול לו. והנה
שם שד״י הוא בתפלין ש״ד
בתפלה של ראש וי׳ בתפלה של
יד. וכשאדם לובש תפלין נמצא
ס״מ תפוס בחניקא די׳ בצואריה
שאינו מתקרב אצלו להחטיאו
וכן במזוזה יש בה שד״י כמו
כן וכן כשהוא לבוש בציצית
בו רמוז שם שדי כדפי׳ בר״מ
הא כיצד שד״י במספר קטן
עולה ח׳ כנגד ח׳ חוטין שבכל
כנף[iii] ולכן בהיות ששם זה רמוז

When a person in his lifetime is wrapped in tzitzit and goes to the entrance of his house, the Holy One, blessed be He, and the Community of Israel rejoice, and the Angel of Death moves away from there, and the person is saved from all harm and destruction. This is the meaning of "throughout their generations" [which can be read as] "to dwell with them." And the word "mezuzot" contains the letters that spell "zaz mavet" [death departs].[1]

Rabbi Nehorai began: "I testify regarding one who goes out wearing the ritual wrap and tefillin on his head—at the time when he passes between the two doorposts, the Divine Presence rests upon him, and two angels stand over him, one on his right and one on his left, and they accompany him to the synagogue."

Furthermore, in Tractate Menachot, chapter HaTechelet, Rabbi Eliezer ben Yaakov says: "Anyone who has tefillin on his head, tefillin on his arm, a mezuzah on his doorpost, and tzitzit on his garment is assured that he will not sin, as it is said: 'And the threefold cord will not quickly be broken' (Ecclesiastes 4:12), and it is also said: 'The angel of the Lord encamps around those who fear Him' (Psalms 34:8)."

The reason is because in Ra'aya Mehemna and in the Tikkunim it states that the divine name Shaddai [שדי] consists of "shed" [שד] and "yod" [י], meaning that the yod is like a noose wrapped around the neck of the demon,[2] holding it so it cannot harm him. Now, the name Shaddai appears in tefillin—the "shin" and "dalet" [ש״ד] in the head tefillin and the "yod" [י] in the arm tefillin. When a person wears tefillin, Samael is caught by the noose of the yod

[1] This is a wordplay typical of kabbalistic interpretation, where Hebrew words are rearranged to reveal hidden meanings. The author suggests that the word 'mezuzot' (doorposts) contains the same letters as 'zaz mavet' (death departs), implying that the mezuzah has power to ward off death.

[2] This vivid imagery explains the kabbalistic understanding of divine names as having protective power. The shape of the Hebrew letter yod (י) is seen as resembling a noose that restrains demonic forces, with the divine name Shaddai (שדי) thus functioning as a spiritual protection mechanism.

[i] This is a wordplay where the Hebrew word 'mezuzot' (doorposts) is reinterpreted as containing the phrase 'zaz mavet' (death departs), suggesting that the mezuzah has protective powers against death.

[ii] The text offers a kabbalistic interpretation of the divine name Shaddai (שדי) as composed of 'shed' (demon) and 'yod' (the tenth Hebrew letter), creating a visual metaphor where the yod functions as a noose controlling the demon.

[iii] This refers to gematria (Hebrew numerology) where 'small numerical value' means adding the numerical values of each letter reduced to single digits. Shin (300→3) + dalet (4) + yod (10→1) = 8, which corresponds to the 8 threads on each corner of the tzitzit.

באלו המצות הוא משבר כחו
60 של ס״מ ומוחזק שלא יחטא וז״ש
חונה מלאך ה׳ סביב ליראיו
במקום מ״ה חונה מלאך ה׳
סביב ליראיו.[i] והזהיר במצות
ציצית בחייו יכוונו בעטיפת
65 הטלית עליו אחר מותו כוונה
זו שאמרנו המתעסקים בתקונו
כי בזה ילך לבטח דרכו לדור
בב״ה עליון ומלאכיו יצוה לו
ושכינת אל על ראשו. ומשם
70 תעלה בצרור החיים וכבר
בארנו בסוד הציצית בח״ב.
ועיין סוד צרורא דחיי בדרוש
השבת פ׳ ויקהל ובפ׳ ויקרא דף
כ״ח. עוד שם איך זוכה אדם
75 במעשיו לרוח ונשמה ומדרגת
כל אחד מהם בעה״ז ובעה״ב
ואז יאמרו פסוק נרד וכרכום
וגו׳. עיין בזהר פ׳ ויקהל דף
כ׳ מפסוק זה ובפ׳ אמור דף
80 ר״פ נתן טעם לקבורה ועיין
למעלה ח״ב. וכבר אמרנו שאין
להשהות המת בלילה[ii] כאשר
כתוב בפ׳ אמור דף פ״ח ובשום
אופן אין לשהותו כ״ד שעות
85 דיהיב חלישותא בשייפוהי
דרתיכא ומעכב עבידתא דקב״ה
מלמעבד[iii] וע״ש ובריקאנ״טי
ריש פ׳ כי תצא:[iv]

around his neck, preventing him from approaching to cause sin. Similarly, the mezuzah contains the name Shaddai, and likewise when one wears tzitzit, the name Shaddai is alluded to, as explained in Ra'aya Mehemna. How so? Shaddai in its small numerical value equals 8,[1] corresponding to the 8 threads on each corner. Therefore, since this name is alluded to in these commandments, it breaks the power of Samael, and one is assured not to sin. This is the meaning of "The angel of the Lord encamps around those who fear Him"—in place of the Angel of Death, the angel of the Lord encamps around those who fear Him.[2]

60R

65R

70R

For one who was careful with the commandment of tzitzit during his lifetime, those attending to his preparation after death should have this intention when wrapping the tallit around him, as we have said. For in this way, he will walk securely on his path to dwell in the supernal house, and "He will command His angels concerning you," and God's Presence will be upon his head. From there, his soul will ascend in the bond of life, and we have already explained the secret of tzitzit in part two. See also the secret of "the bond of life" in the discourse on Shabbat in Parashat Vayakhel and in Parashat Vayikra, page 25. There it also explains how a person merits through his deeds to attain ruach and neshamah, and the level of each of them in this world and in the World to Come.

75R

80R

85R

Then they should recite the verse: "Nard and

[1] This refers to 'mispar katan' (small number), a system of Hebrew numerology where letter values above 9 are reduced by adding their digits. Thus Shin (300→3) + Dalet (4) + Yod (10→1) = 8, which corresponds to the 8 threads on each corner of the tzitzit.

[2] The text uses a wordplay on 'מ״ה' which could be read as an abbreviation for 'Malach HaMavet' (Angel of Death). The verse is interpreted to mean that the protective angel replaces the destructive one for those who observe the commandments.

[i] The text uses wordplay to suggest that 'in place of M"H' (where M"H is an abbreviation for Malach HaMavet—the Angel of Death), the angel of the Lord surrounds the righteous, offering protection.

[ii] The prohibition against delaying burial overnight is an important Jewish burial practice, based on Deuteronomy 21:23. The text here reinforces this with mystical reasoning about its cosmic effects.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase explains that delaying burial causes 'weakness in the limbs of the Divine Chariot' and 'impedes the work of the Holy One, blessed be He.' In kabbalistic thought, the human body corresponds to the divine structure, so proper treatment of the deceased has cosmic implications.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The Zohar passage explains how the different components of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) require different spiritual garments in the afterlife, which are symbolized by the physical burial garments. This reference provides the kabbalistic basis for the burial clothing practices described. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This Zohar passage

saffron..." (Song of Songs 4:14). See in the Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel, page 20, regarding this verse, and in Parashat Emor, page 280, where it gives a reason for burial. See also above in part two.

We have already stated that one should not keep the deceased overnight, as written in Parashat Emor, page 88, and under no circumstances should one delay for 24 hours, for this causes weakness in the limbs of the Divine Chariot and impedes the work of the Holy One,[1] blessed be He, from being accomplished. See there and in Recanati at the beginning of Parashat Ki Tetze.

פרק י״ד

Chapter 14

ואחר שהלבישוהו יאמרו עוד לסוד הלבשת בגדים הרוחניים שוש אשיש בה׳ וגו׳[i] ויאמר כשמתקן כסוי ראשו בעטופא דמצוה ואומר ישימו צניף טהור וגו׳.[ii] עיין מפסוק זה פ׳ שלח

After they have dressed him,[2] they should further recite, regarding the mystery of clothing in spiritual garments:[3] "I will greatly rejoice in the LORD" etc. And when arranging the covering of his head with the ritual wrapping,[4] they should say: "Let them place a pure diadem" etc. Examine this verse in

[1]This expresses the kabbalistic belief that human actions have cosmic consequences. Delaying burial is understood to affect negative changes in the divine realm, specifically in the 'Divine Chariot' (merkavah), a mystical concept based on Ezekiel's vision that represents the structure of divine governance.

[2]This section deals with the next stage of tahara (ritual purification of the deceased) after the washing and dressing in burial shrouds has been completed. The text now focuses on the spiritual dimensions of these physical acts.

[3]In Kabbalah, physical garments represent spiritual vessels or 'clothing' for the soul. The burial shrouds have a corresponding spiritual reality that helps the soul transition to the next world.

[4]This likely refers to wrapping the deceased's head with a cloth similar to how the tallit (prayer shawl) might be wrapped during prayer, emphasizing the sacred nature of the preparation.

likely connects the aromatic spices mentioned in Song of Songs to the spiritual fragrances that accompany the soul's ascent, providing mystical context for why this verse should be recited during burial preparations. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Emor — This section of the Zohar provides the kabbalistic rationale for burial, explaining how proper burial facilitates the soul's journey in the afterlife. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Emor — This Zohar passage explains the spiritual harm caused by delaying burial, suggesting that it disrupts cosmic processes and causes distress to both the soul and the Divine realms. | Cf. Tractate Menachot — This Talmudic reference establishes the protective power of ritual objects like tzitzit and tefillin, which is then applied in Ma'avar Yabok to explain why these items are significant in burial preparations. The reference supports the idea that these ritual objects continue to provide spiritual protection even after death. | Cf. Recanati — Recanati (Rabbi Menahem Recanati) was a prominent kabbalist whose commentary would provide additional mystical insights about burial timing and practices, reinforcing the cosmic importance of proper burial procedures. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — This section of Ra'aya Mehemna (a part of the Zohar) explains the mystical encoding of divine names in ritual objects like tzitzit and tefillin, providing the theoretical basis for their protective powers against negative spiritual forces.

[i]From Isaiah 61:10, "I will greatly rejoice in the LORD; my soul shall exult in my God, for He has clothed me with garments of salvation, He has covered me with the robe of righteousness." This verse connects physical dressing with spiritual clothing in divine attributes.

[ii]From Zechariah 3:5, "Let them place a pure diadem on his head." This verse comes from a vision of Joshua the High Priest being clothed in clean garments, symbolizing spiritual purification.

לך דף קס״ט ע״ב ושם למה השטן
היה מקטרג בלבושי יהושע אחר
שנטלה נשמתו כבר. ושם מתבאר
בפרטות כל חלקי גוף האדם
מלמעלה בהדרגה אחר שפי׳
מוצא הנר״ן וטעם למה נאמר
חלוץ בעצמות ולא בבשר[i] עוד
בלבושי יהושע בפ׳ בלק דף
קפ״ה ע״ב נתן טעם למה נדון
האדם המת במתיבתא דרקיעא.
עוד יאמרו כי בארץ תוציא
צמחה וגו׳.[ii] ונחך ה׳ תמיד
וגו׳.[iii] והיית כגן רוה וגו׳. ואין
לחוש לדברי המונעים מלומר
דברים שבקדושה במקום המת
באמרם כי המת מטמא. כי לא
נמצא שאסרו רבנן רק לומר ד״ת
במקום הטנופת כי שם הרגיעה
לילית[iv] והם צריכים הבדלה
לא עירוב וכבר פירשו מה
הם דברים המטנפים צואה ומי
רגלים וצואת חמור הרכה ובית
המרחץ ובית הכסא ואביזרייהו
ומקום שרואה בו ערוה משום
ולא יראה בך ערות דבר אבל
אין אסור לומר ד״ת במקום
טומאה שאינם מקבלים טומאה
ומקום טנופת לחוד ומקום
טומאה לחוד וכבר איפסיקא
הלכתא כר״י בן בתירא כדאיתא
פ׳ מי שמתו ורב הונא דאמר

Parashat Shelach Lecha, page 169b, where it explains why Satan accused Joshua regarding his garments after his soul had already been taken. There, all parts of the human body are explained in detail hierarchically from above, after explaining the origin of the Neshamah, Ruach, and Nefesh,[1] and the reason why "barefoot" is mentioned regarding bones and not flesh. Additionally, concerning Joshua's garments in Parashat Balak, page 185b, a reason is given for why the deceased person is judged in the heavenly academy. 10R 15R

They should further recite: "For as the earth brings forth its sprouts" etc., "And the LORD will guide you continually" etc., "And you shall be like a watered garden" etc. One need not be concerned about those who prohibit saying sacred words in the presence of the dead,[2] claiming that the dead renders impure. For the Rabbis only prohibited saying words of Torah in a place of filth, where Lilith finds repose, as such places require separation, not mixture. They have already explained which things are considered filth: excrement, urine, soft donkey dung, the bathhouse, the toilet and their surroundings, and a place where nakedness is visible, because of "that He see no unseemly thing among you." But it is not forbidden to recite words of Torah in a place of ritual impurity that does not receive impurity; a place of filth is one category and a place of impurity is another.[3] The law has already been decided according to Rabbi Yehudah ben Beterah, as stated in the chapter "One Whose Dead Relative" [Berakhot]. And Rav Huna, 20R 25R 30R 35R

[1] These are the three primary levels of the soul in Kabbalistic thought, in descending order of spiritual refinement: Neshamah (highest soul), Ruach (spirit), and Nefesh (vital soul).
[2] The text addresses a practical halakhic question about whether sacred prayers and texts can be recited in the presence of a corpse. This reflects actual debates among Jewish legal authorities.
[3] The author makes an important legal distinction between ritual impurity (tumah) which is not inherently negative and filth (tinuf) which is problematic for prayer. A corpse causes ritual impurity but is not considered filth.

[i] "Barefoot" or "drawn out" is associated with bones rather than flesh, likely referring to the kabbalistic concept that the bones retain a connection to the soul after death.
[ii] From Isaiah 61:11, "For as the earth brings forth its sprouts, and as a garden causes what is sown in it to sprout up, so the Lord GOD will cause righteousness and praise to sprout up before all the nations." This verse metaphorically connects burial with the promise of future resurrection.
[iii] From Isaiah 58:11, "And the LORD will guide you continually and satisfy your desire in scorched places and make your bones strong; and you shall be like a watered garden, like a spring of water, whose waters do not fail." The reference to bones being strengthened is particularly relevant in the burial context.
[iv] Lilith is a female demonic figure in Jewish mysticism, associated with impurity and death. The text refers to the concept that Lilith finds rest in places of filth, which is why Torah study is prohibited there.

ת״ח אסור לעמוד במקום טנופת
משום שא״א לו בלא תורה לא
40 אמר במקום טומאה ואי משום
ערות המת אם היא מכוסות אין
להקפיד דרחמנא אמר ולא יראה
בך ערות דבר והא לא מתחזיא.
וכשמכניסין אותו בארון יכוונו
45 להטמין גופו ולבושיו עליונים
בתחתונים מכחות בעלי הדין
והוא נטמן בסוד עץ החיים. עוד
יכוונו שגופו בסוד וא״ו ובריתו
משך וא״ו נכנס בסוד התיבה
50 בסוד נח איש צדיק בתיבה[i] והוא
השושבין המייחד סוד וא״ו ת״ת
במלכות בסוד וה׳ בהיכל קדשו
וב׳ ציציות עליונות עם הב׳
תחתונות הם לרמז כחות מקבלים
55 דמתייחדין עם כחות משפיעים
בסוד וקרא ז״ה אל ז״ה ואמר
קדוש קדוש קדוש.[ii] יחוד זה
גורם כניסת נפש הצדיק למעלה
במקורה העליון במקום מוצאה
60 שהיא מארון הברית אדון כל
הארץ שמתרבה הכבוד העליון
בעליית נר״ן הצדיק עם אלומות
מעשיו המתייחדים ומאירים יחד
כלם בארץ העליונה ולדרים
65 בחצרות אל בנזכר למעלה. וזה
רמז אמירת פסוק שמע ישראל
ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד בעת סלוק
הנשמה ובנסת ישראל משוררת

who said that a Torah scholar is forbidden to stand in a place of filth because he cannot be without Torah, did not say "in a place of impurity." And regarding 40R
the nakedness of the dead, if it is covered, there is no concern, for the Torah said, "that He see no unseemly thing among you," and in this case, it is not visible.

When placing him in the coffin,[1] they should intend to hide his body and his upper garments within 45R
the lower ones from the forces of judgment. He is concealed in the mystery of the Tree of Life. They should further intend that his body is in the mystery of the letter Vav,[2] and his covenant, which extends as
a Vav, enters into the mystery of the ark, in the mys- 50R
tery of "Noah, a righteous man" in the ark. He is the attendant who unifies[3] the mystery of Vav (Tiferet) with Malkhut, in the mystery of "the LORD is in His holy Temple." The two upper tzitzit with the two lower ones[4] symbolize the receiving forces that 55R
unite with the bestowing forces, in the mystery of "And one called unto another and said: Holy, holy, holy."

This unification causes the righteous person's soul to enter its supernal source,[5] in the place of its 60R
origin, which is from the Ark of the Covenant, the Master of all the earth. The supernal glory increases through the ascent of the righteous person's Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah, together with the sheaves of his deeds, which unite and illuminate together in the 65R
supernal land and for those dwelling in God's courts, as mentioned above. This is the allusion of reciting "Hear, O Israel, the LORD our God, the LORD

[1] This begins the section on the spiritual significance of placing the body in the coffin, introducing several kabbalistic concepts that reveal the deeper mystical meaning of this act.
[2] In Kabbalah, the letter vav (ו) which looks like a vertical line, represents the human body and the divine attribute of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony). The human body is seen as a channel connecting heaven and earth, just as the letter vav connects letters in Hebrew words.
[3] In Kabbalistic symbolism, the 'attendant' (shoshvin) is one who facilitates divine unions. Here, the deceased person's body itself serves as a conduit for unifying divine masculine and feminine attributes (Tiferet and Malkhut).
[4] This refers to the ritual fringes (tzitzit) on the tallit (prayer shawl) that may be placed on the deceased. The four corners represent different aspects of divinity that are unified through proper ritual.
[5] According to Kabbalah, proper burial rituals facilitate the soul's return to its divine source. Physical actions in this world create corresponding spiritual effects in higher realms.

[i] "Noah, a righteous man" in the ark is used as a metaphor for the soul being protected in the coffin, with kabbalistic connections between the biblical flood narrative and the soul's journey after death.
[ii] From Isaiah 6:3, "And one called to another and said: 'Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts; the whole earth is full of His glory!'" The text interprets this as representing the unification of receiving and bestowing spiritual forces.

לפני המלך העליון וזהו בא יבא
ברנה נושא אלומותיו[i] ובודאי כי
מדת ז״את תענה ותאמר לו שלום
בואו. ועיין בזהר פרשת ויקהל
טעם הכנסת הגוף בארון. ויאמרו
בעת הכנסתו. ולא יבואו לראות
כבלע את הקדש ומתו.[ii] ואם
הוא אדם חשוב יאמרו אותו
ג׳ פעמים בקול רם ואחר
שכסוהו בארון יאמרו. ראיתי
והנה מנורת זהב וגו׳.[iii] ויכוין
להשפעות המנורות משבעה
מוצקות עליונות עם שנים
זיתים שעליהם שהם שתי גולות
הכותרות ויחד כלם מריקים
בצדיק יסוד עולם[iv] ומשם על
ארון הברית העליונה ויחוד
זה גורם עליית נפש הצדיקים
ועיין בזהר פ׳ ויחי סוד קבורת
צדיק בארון. אח״כ יאמר בשבח
הכבוד העליון. מי אתה הר
הגדול וגו׳.[v] ועתה יגדל נא כח
אדני כאשר דברת לאמר. ואולם
חי אני וימלא כבוד ה׳ את כל
הארץ. ואם הוא בעל תורה נראה
לי שטוב לעשות צרכיו במקום
שעסק בתורה שם כנזכר למעלה
שמצינו בפ׳ פנחס שהצדיקים
פוקדים מקום שהיו מחדשים שם

is One" at the time of the soul's departure, and the Community of Israel sings before the supernal King.[1] This is the meaning of "He shall come in with rejoicing, bearing his sheaves," and certainly the attribute of ZOT will respond and say to him, "Peace upon your coming." See the Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel, for the reason for placing the body in a coffin.

At the time of placing him in the coffin, they should say: "But they shall not go in to see the holy things as they are being covered, lest they die." If he is a distinguished person, they should recite this three times in a loud voice. After covering him in the coffin, they should say: "I saw, and behold a menorah of gold" etc. One should focus on the influences of the menorahs from the seven supernal bowls[2] with the two olive trees above them, which are the two spherical capitals. Together, they all pour into the righteous person, the foundation of the world, and from there onto the supernal Ark of the Covenant. This unification causes the ascent of the souls of the righteous. See the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, for the mystery of burying a righteous person in a coffin.

Afterward, one should recite in praise of the supernal glory: "Who are you, O great mountain" etc., "And now, let the power of my Lord be great, as You have spoken, saying," "But as truly as I live, all the earth shall be filled with the glory of the LORD." If he was a Torah scholar,[3] it seems to me

[1] The 'Community of Israel' (Knesset Yisrael) is a kabbalistic term for the Shekhinah, the divine feminine presence. The text describes a mystical reception ceremony for the ascending soul.

[2] This references the kabbalistic interpretation of Zechariah's vision (4:2-3), where the menorah represents divine channels through which spiritual illumination flows from higher realms to lower ones.

[3] The text gives special instructions for Torah scholars, reflecting the belief that they have a unique

[i] From Psalm 126:6, "He who goes out weeping, bearing the seed for sowing, shall come home with shouts of joy, bringing his sheaves with him." This is interpreted as the soul returning to its divine source carrying the merit of its good deeds.

[ii] From Numbers 4:20, "But they shall not go in to see the holy things as they are being covered, lest they die." This verse originally referred to the prohibition against unauthorized viewing of sacred objects in the Tabernacle but is applied here to the covering of the deceased in the coffin.

[iii] From Zechariah 4:2, "And he said to me, 'What do you see?' I said, 'I see, and behold, a lampstand all of gold, with a bowl on the top of it, and seven lamps on it, with seven lips on each of the lamps that are on the top of it.'" This verse introduces a vision with rich kabbalistic symbolism of divine illumination flowing through various channels.

[iv] "The righteous person, foundation of the world" combines Proverbs 10:25 with kabbalistic terminology, where the righteous person corresponds to the divine attribute of Yesod (Foundation), which channels divine flow between the upper sefirot and Malkhut.

[v] From Zechariah 4:7, "Who are you, O great mountain? Before Zerubbabel you shall become a plain." In the context of burial, this may refer to overcoming obstacles in the soul's journey to its spiritual source.

ד״ת וכ״ש כד שראן בגויה אחרינן בההוא אתר במליה דאורייתא
100 והביא מעשה דר׳ פנחס בן יאיר שנראה שם בדמות ההוא טולא וזה בסוד ויהללוה בשערים מעשיה[i] שרושם הקדושה אינו מסתלק ממקומו הראשון לעולם
105 אך מתרחב והולך ומתפשט עד אין תכלית:[ii]

that it is good to attend to his needs in the place where he studied Torah, as mentioned above. For we find in Parashat Pinchas that the righteous visit 100R
the place where they innovated words of Torah, especially "when others dwell in that place [and engage] in his words of Torah." It brings the story of Rabbi Pinchas ben Yair who appeared there in the form of
that shadow. This is in the mystery of "Her works 105R
praise her in the gates," for the imprint of holiness never departs from its original place[1] but expands, proceeds, and extends without limit.

פרק ט״ו

Chapter 15

כשבאין הכתפים לשאת אותו ובפרט אם הוא ת״ח יאמרו ובנסוע המשכן יורידו אותו הלוים וגו׳. ויהי בנסוע
5 הארון וגו׳. כי מלאכיו יצוה לך וגו׳. על כפים ישאונך ויסיימו המזמור. ומה טוב שכל המתחלפים תחת הארגז

When the pallbearers come to carry the deceased,[2] especially if he is a Torah scholar, they should recite: "When the Tabernacle is to journey, the Levites shall take it down..." (Numbers 1:51),
"When the Ark set out..." (Numbers 10:35), 5R
"For He will command His angels concerning you..." (Psalms 91:11), "They will bear you up in their hands..."[3] and complete the psalm. It is

spiritual status and connection to the places where they studied and taught.

[1]This expresses the kabbalistic concept that spiritual actions create permanent impressions in physical space. The holiness generated through Torah study remains in that location indefinitely.

[2]The Hebrew term 'katafim' literally means 'shoulders,' referring to those who carry the coffin on their shoulders, a traditional practice in Jewish funerals.

[3]This continues the quote from Psalm 91:12, which speaks of angelic protection. These verses from Psalm 91 are traditionally recited for protection against harmful spiritual forces.

[i]From Proverbs 31:31, "Give her of the fruit of her hands, and let her works praise her in the gates." This verse is interpreted to mean that the impact of one's Torah study and good deeds continues to create spiritual effects in their original locations even after death.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shelach Lecha, page 169b — This Zohar passage explains why Satan would accuse the deceased regarding their spiritual garments even after death, suggesting the ongoing spiritual battles that occur during the soul's transition. This reference deepens the reader's understanding of why proper burial garments have mystical significance. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Balak, page 185b — This Zohar passage explains that even after death, the soul undergoes judgment in the heavenly academy. The reference emphasizes the continuity of spiritual existence after physical death and the importance of proper preparation through ritual burial practices. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This reference points to a Zohar passage that explains the spiritual significance of placing the body in a coffin. This likely includes kabbalistic concepts about the protection of the physical vessel and its relationship to the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — This reference highlights that there are special mystical dimensions to the burial of particularly righteous individuals. The Zohar in Parashat Vayechi would elaborate on how the burial of tzaddikim (righteous ones) has unique spiritual effects. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas — This reference presents the concept that the souls of the righteous continue to visit places where they studied and taught Torah. This informs the recommendation to prepare the deceased Torah scholar in the place where he studied, as there is a special connection between his soul and that location. | Cf. Berakhot, Chapter 'One Whose Dead Relative' (Mi SheMeto) — This reference establishes the halakhic (legal) foundation for permitting sacred recitations in the presence of the dead, countering those who might prohibit such practices. The author uses this to justify the prayers and biblical verses recommended during burial preparations.

יאמרו כל א׳ מהם פסוקים אלו.[i] ופסוקים שרפים עומדים ממעל לו וגו׳ מסוגל לאדם גדול[ii] ויכוונו להעלותו בסתר עליון להתייחד במדרגות אשר מעל ראשי כתפין כנזכר למעלה. ואמרו בתקונים דף רל״ח כי נשיאת המת הצדיק על הכתף הוא בסוד ויביאו את המשכן אל משה[iii] ובנסוע המשכן שהיא הנשמה הזאת הממושכנת בעוה״ז בעל כרחה בירידתה בעה״ז[iv] יורידו אותו הלוים כדכתיב כי מלאכיו יצוה לך כדפי׳ למעלה וגם בחנות המשכן בשהולכת למקום מנוחתה יש ללויתה שרפי קדש אשר פעל ומלאכין אין מספר מול צדקותיו אשר עשה[v] כדכתיב הנה צדקתו אתו ופעולתו לפניו ושכר מעשיו גורם הדבקות עם השכינה בעצם. באופן כי הזר הקרב יומת פי׳ הזר הקרב לנגד נשמה זו יומת ויבולע[vi] כי סקל המסלה ופנה לו דרך לעלות לה׳ בלי עכוב. וקול קורא

good that each person who takes turns beneath the coffin should recite these verses. The verses "Seraphim stood above Him..." (Isaiah 6:2) are especially effective for a distinguished person, and they should intend to elevate him to the supernal concealment,[1] to unite at the levels above the heads of the bearers as mentioned earlier.

It is stated in Tikkunim, page 238, that carrying the righteous deceased on the shoulder corresponds to the mystery of "And they brought the Tabernacle to Moses" (Exodus 39:33). The phrase "When the Tabernacle journeys" refers to this soul that was reluctantly pledged in this world during its descent.[2] "The Levites shall take it down," as it is written, "For He will command His angels concerning you," as explained above. And also when the Tabernacle rests, as the soul goes to its resting place, it is accompanied by holy seraphim which it created through its deeds,[3] and countless angels corresponding to the righteous acts it performed, as it is written, "Behold, his righteousness goes with him, and his work before him" (Isaiah 62:11). The reward for his deeds causes actual cleaving to the Divine Presence.

Thus, "any stranger who comes near shall be put to death" means that any external force approaching

[1] This mystical phrase refers to elevating the soul to higher spiritual realms. In Kabbalah, 'seter elyon' (supernal concealment) refers to the hidden divine realm where souls unite with their spiritual source.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that souls are reluctant to descend into physical bodies, viewing incarnation as a form of temporary exile from their divine source.

[3] According to kabbalistic thought, each good deed (mitzvah) performed by a person creates an actual angel or spiritual entity that accompanies the soul after death and advocates for it in the heavenly court.

[i] This describes the practice of pallbearers taking turns carrying the coffin, with each new bearer reciting specific biblical verses when they take their position. This rotation system distributes the physical burden while maintaining continuous spiritual protection through sacred recitations.

[ii] The reference to Isaiah 6:2 ('Seraphim stood above Him') is specifically recommended for distinguished individuals or Torah scholars, suggesting a hierarchical approach to funeral rituals where different verses are appropriate based on the deceased's spiritual status.

[iii] This establishes a mystical parallel between the pallbearers carrying the deceased and the Israelites bringing the completed Tabernacle to Moses (Exodus 39:33), suggesting that funeral rituals reenact sacred biblical events with cosmic significance.

[iv] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the soul descends reluctantly into this world, viewing physical incarnation as a form of captivity or pledge (mashkon) that will eventually be redeemed when the soul returns to its source.

[v] This expresses the belief that the righteous person's good deeds create actual angels that accompany the soul after death. Each mitzvah performed in life generates spiritual entities that escort the deceased in death.

[vi] The verse about strangers being put to death if they approach the Tabernacle is reinterpreted mystically to mean that negative spiritual entities ('external forces') will be destroyed if they attempt to interfere with the soul's journey after death.

במדבר שהם כחות החצונים השוכנים במקום חורב פנו דרך ה׳ וגו׳. ואם כן המלוים המת נעשים מרכבה למלוים עליונים. וכמו שהם מלוים גופו למטה בגופם כן יכוונו ללוות נפשו בסוד נפשם ורוחו ברוחם ונשמתו בנשמתם[i] כי נשמת המת ורוחו ונפשו מלוים הגוף לקבר כדאמרי׳ דהתם קאימנא ולא לחנם הזהירו חכמים כל כך בכבוד המת ובלוייתו ואמרו הרואה את המת ואינו מלוהו. עובר משום לועג לרש[ii] ודברים הרבה כיוצא בזה כי ודאי לא כוונו אל הכבוד המדומה לגוף בלבד ובפרט כי מהנראה לעין הוא אבן מעמסה. וכתוב באדרות חיים של רבי אליעזר הגדול בני הוי זהיר להוצאת הקבר להכניסו ביד קונך כי מצוה גדולה היא עליך כל העושה חסד חנם הקב״ה עושה לו חסד של חנם. ובכל זמן שעומדים עם הארגז להחליף יכוונו להבריח מעליו ומסביביו הרוחות כי בכל עמידה הרוחות פורחים[iii] ואולי שאין להם רשות רק להלך לא לעמוד כמו שהמזיק אין לו רשות לזוז ממקומו ואולי הרוחות נקראות פורחות על זה כדכתיב

against this soul shall be destroyed[1] and swallowed up, for the path has been cleared and a way prepared for him to ascend to God without hindrance. "A voice calls in the wilderness" refers to the external forces dwelling in desolate places: "Clear the way of the Lord..." (Isaiah 40:3). Therefore, those who accompany the deceased become a vehicle for the supernal escorts. Just as they accompany his body below with their bodies, they should intend to accompany his soul with the essence of their souls, his spirit with their spirits, and his higher soul with their higher souls,[2] for the deceased's soul, spirit, and vital soul accompany the body to the grave, as they say, "I stand there."

Not without reason did the Sages so emphatically warn about honoring the deceased and accompanying him, saying that one who sees the deceased and does not accompany him transgresses "mocking the poor"[3] (Proverbs 17:5), and many similar statements. They certainly did not intend merely the imagined honor for the body alone, especially since to the eye it appears as a burdensome stone. It is written in Orchot Chaim by Rabbi Eliezer the Great: "My son, be careful about bringing the deceased to burial, to place him in the hand of his Creator, for this is a great commandment incumbent upon you. For anyone who performs gratuitous kindness, the Holy One, blessed be He, performs gratuitous kindness for him."

Whenever they stop with the coffin to change bearers, they should intend to drive away the spirits

[1]The 'external forces' (kochot ha-chitzonim) refer to negative spiritual entities in kabbalistic thought that might attempt to interfere with the soul's journey after death. The funeral rituals are partly designed to protect against these forces.

[2]This reflects the kabbalistic understanding of the soul's three primary levels: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). Funeral participants are instructed to escort each level of the deceased's soul with the corresponding level of their own souls.

[3]The biblical prohibition against 'mocking the poor' (Proverbs 17:5) is applied here to those who fail to participate in funeral processions, reinterpreting the 'poor' (rash) as the deceased who can no longer perform mitzvot.

[i]This presents a sophisticated understanding of how funeral participants should escort the deceased: not just physically accompanying the body, but spiritually accompanying each level of the departed's soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) with the corresponding level of their own souls.

[ii]The biblical prohibition against 'mocking the poor' (Proverbs 17:5) is applied to those who fail to accompany the deceased, reinterpreting the 'poor' as the dead who lack the ability to perform further mitzvot.

[iii]This reflects a belief that harmful spirits gather around the deceased but scatter when the pallbearers stop to change positions, suggesting a protective spiritual function to the practice of periodically pausing and changing bearers.

ונפשותיכן לפורחות.[i] וזה כלל
גדול בכל צרכי גופו יכוונו
בעצם ובראשונה לתקן נשמתו
בסוד כוונתם העולה עד סוד
70 נשמתם למעלה וזהו חסד של 70R
אמת ודאי יכוונו להשפיע כח
האלף על מת וזהו אמת[ii] כנדרש
למעלה. והסדר שתקן יעקב
אבינו לבניו בנשיאת מטתו
75 כדאמרי׳ במדרש רבה פ׳ ב׳ 75R
כיון שבא יעקב אבינו ליפטר
מן העולם קרא לבניו וצום
וזרזם על דרכי האלהים וקבלו
עליהם מלכות שמים משגמר
80 דבריו אמר להם כשתטלו אותי 80R
ביראה וכבוד לוו אותי ולא יגע
אדם אחר במטתי וכן ממה שצוה
רבינו הקדוש וממה שנתבאר
בסוף אדרת האזינו בקבורת
85 רבי שמעון בן יוחאי נראה 85R
בפירוש כי כבוד והדר ונייחא
רבא אית לצדיקים כשאנשים
הגונים מתעסקים בהם אחר
פטירתם ולא כל הרוצה ליטול
90 את השם יטול[iii] ואם בכניסת חתן 90R
וכלה לחופה מנהג להעשות ע״י
גדול כ״ש וק״ו להכניס הנשמה
והנלוים אליה עם הגוף למקום
משכן כבודם כי כבוד יעשו לו
95 במותו ע״י אנשים של צורה. 95R
וא״ר שמעון בן יוחאי בפ׳ נגמר
הדין כי קבורה מן התורה מפסוק
כי קבור תקברנו ביום ההוא

from around him, for at every stopping the spirits fly away.[1] Perhaps they are only permitted to walk, not to stand, just as a harmful entity is not permitted to move from its place. Perhaps the spirits are called "flyers" for this reason, as it is written, "And your souls for flying away" (Ezekiel 13:20).

This is a great principle regarding all the needs of his body: they should primarily intend to rectify his soul through the power of their intention, which ascends to the mystery of their souls above. This is certainly true kindness. They should intend to channel the power of the letter Alef upon the deceased,[2] and this is "truth" (emet), as explained above.

The order that our father Jacob established for his sons in carrying his bier, as stated in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 2: When our father Jacob was about to depart from the world,[3] he called his sons and commanded them and urged them regarding the ways of God, and they accepted upon themselves the kingdom of heaven. When he finished speaking, he said to them, "When you carry me, do so with reverence and honor. Accompany me, and let no other person touch my bier." Similarly, from what our holy Rabbi commanded, and from what is explained at the end of Idra Ha'azinu regarding the burial of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, it is explicitly seen that great honor, glory, and satisfaction come to the righteous when worthy people attend to them after their passing, and not just anyone who wishes to take the name. And if the custom for a bride and groom's entry to the wedding canopy is to be performed by a distinguished person, how much more so should bringing the soul and its

[1] This reflects a belief that harmful spiritual entities gather around the deceased but are scattered when the pallbearers pause to change positions, suggesting that the practice of rotating bearers serves not just practical but spiritual protective functions.

[2] In Jewish mysticism, the letter Alef (א) represents divine unity and is the first letter of 'emet' (truth). The passage suggests directing this spiritual energy toward the deceased as part of true kindness (chesed shel emet).

[3] The text draws on the example of Jacob's burial preparations as a biblical precedent for proper funeral protocols, emphasizing that these practices have ancient and authoritative roots.

[i] This is a reference to Ezekiel 13:20, which in context refers to false prophetesses who 'hunt souls like birds.' The text creatively reinterprets this verse to explain why spirits are called 'flyers' or 'flying ones.'

[ii] This refers to a kabbalistic concept where the letter Alef (א) represents divine unity and truth. By directing the 'power of the Alef' toward the deceased, the funeral participants infuse the burial with the quality of 'emet' (truth), transforming it into 'chesed shel emet' (true kindness).

[iii] This expression means 'not anyone who wishes to take the name may take it,' implying that not everyone is worthy of performing this sacred duty. It emphasizes that funeral rituals should be performed by appropriate people rather than anyone who simply wants the honor.

ובירו׳ פ׳ אלו עוברים אמר כי
100 לויית המת קודם לת״ת.[i] וחכמי
המשנה חשבו דבר זה לזכות
גדול יוסף זכה לקבור את אביו
וכו׳. מי לנו גדול ממשה שלא
נתעסק בו וכו׳ ובעת הלוייה
105 יכוונו ללוות הקדושה עמו בכח
ניצוצות נשמת כל אחד מהם
שהקדושה חופפת ושוכנת בכל
עדה מישראל כדכתיב ונקדשתי
בתוך בני ישראל וכבר אמרנו
110 כי היודע סוד הלוייה לחיים
ממנה יבין צורך הלוייה למת.
ועוד יתוסף ללוויית המת כוונות
אחרות ואין זה מקומן ונרמז
קצת מהכוונה של הלוייה בזהר
115 פ׳ וירא דף קכ״ו ולא לחנם ת״ת
נדחה מפניה ולמאן דמתני ליה
ליה שעורא:[ii]

accompaniments with the body to their resting place of honor be done through people of stature, for honor shall be given to him in his death through people of worthy appearance. 100R

Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai said in the chapter "The Judgment is Concluded" that burial is mandated by the Torah from the verse[1] "You shall surely bury him on that day" (Deuteronomy 21:23). And in the Jerusalem Talmud, chapter "These Pass," he said that accompanying the deceased takes precedence over Torah study.[2] The Sages of the Mishnah considered this a great merit: "Joseph merited to bury his father," etc. "Who is greater than Moses, who was not occupied with [Joseph's burial]," etc. 105R 110R

During the funeral procession, they should intend to accompany the holiness with him through the power of the soul-sparks of each of them, for holiness hovers and dwells within every congregation of Israel,[3] as it is written, "I shall be sanctified among the children of Israel" (Leviticus 22:32). We have already stated that one who knows the secret of accompanying the living will understand from it the necessity of accompanying the deceased. There are additional intentions for accompanying the deceased, but this is not the place for them. Some of the intention behind accompaniment is hinted at in the Zohar, Parashat Vayera, page 126. Not without reason is Torah study postponed for it, and for one who studies there is no limit. 115R 120R 125R

[1] The text establishes the biblical basis for burial, citing Deuteronomy 21:23 as proof that proper burial is a Torah obligation rather than merely a tradition.

[2] This establishes a striking halakhic principle that participating in funeral processions takes priority over Torah study, which is otherwise considered equal to all other commandments combined. This underscores the exceptional importance of honoring the dead in Jewish tradition.

[3] This refers to the concept that the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) resides within the Jewish community, especially when gathered for sacred purposes. The funeral procession thus becomes a vehicle for channeling divine energy to assist the deceased.

[i] This establishes that accompanying the deceased takes precedence over Torah study (talmud torah), which is otherwise considered equal to all other commandments combined. This emphasizes the exceptional importance of participating in funeral processions.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayera — The Zohar passage referenced here provides deeper mystical explanations about the importance of accompanying the deceased, suggesting that the funeral procession has cosmic significance beyond its visible ritual aspects. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The text directly quotes from Tikkunei Zohar to establish a mystical parallel between carrying the deceased and bringing the Tabernacle to Moses, suggesting that funeral rituals have deeper cosmic significance mirroring sacred biblical events. | Cf. Idra Ha'azinu — The reference to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's burial in the Idra Ha'azinu section of the Zohar is used to emphasize that righteous individuals should be buried by worthy people, suggesting that who performs the burial has spiritual significance. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah — The text cites Midrash Rabbah regarding Jacob's final instructions to his sons about his funeral arrangements, using this as a biblical precedent for the proper conduct of funeral bearers.

פרק ט״ז

Chapter 16

תורה מפי יודעי דעת תצא כי מהתקון הששי שבזקן עליון שהיא סוד השרשת הגבורות בבינה והבינה בכתר וסוד י״ג תקוני דיקני הם סוד השער התפשטות ווין מסוד הספירות ויש חמש בחינות בכתר להמתקת הדינין הראשון כל עצמו של כתר דכתיב ביה כורסיה שביבין דנור שיושב על כסאו שהוא זעיר כאומרו ועתיק יומין יתיב עליו לכפות דיניו. הב׳ גלוי סוד מצח הרצון שמשכך הדין ואפי׳ אש גהינם נשקע. הג׳ עינא פקיחא דזעיר המאיר לספירת גבורה הוד מלכות והם מתרחצות מדינים ובכח זה עיינין דזעיר רוחצות בחלב. הד׳ בסוד חוטמא עושה למטה נחת רוח וממנו קבלת התפלה כדכתיב ותהלתי אחטם לך. הה׳ בסוד דיקנא שכל מציאותה לבטל הדינים ובטולם בי״ג דרכים שונים. ותקון הששי שמתראה בצורה הגשמית בסוד שבולת הזקן והוא שער שמכסה הזקן מראש הפה עד ראש הפה מלמטה ונקרא חפץ חסד במדות מי אל כמוך ובמדות אל רחום הוא ואמ״ת ותקון הזה הוא קשר נ״ה עם היסוד ודרך נ״ה עובר אל המלכות ונצח הוא חפץ בהמשכת החסד וכן במדות נותן טעם ורב חסד ואמת נקשר רב חסד עם האמת הזה כי נצח נקשר באמת. ולכן נקראים נביאי האמת נביאי קשוט ומבטל הדינים בהמשכת החסדים והחסד תלוי בשרש זה.

The Torah comes forth from those who know wisdom, for from the sixth rectification of the supernal beard, which is the secret of the embedding of Gevurot (powers of judgment) in Binah (Understanding), and Binah in Keter (Crown).[1] The secret of the thirteen rectifications of the beard is the secret of the hairs extending as Vavs from the secret of the Sefirot.[2] There are five aspects in Keter for sweetening judgments: First, the entire essence of Keter, of which it is written "His throne was fiery flames," as He sits upon His throne, which is Zeir Anpin (the Lesser Countenance), as it says, "And the Ancient of Days sat" upon it to subdue its judgments. Second, the revelation of the secret of the Forehead of Will, which calms judgment, and even the fire of Gehenna is quenched. Third, the watchful eye of Zeir Anpin that illuminates the Sefirot of Gevurah, Hod, and Malkhut, and they are cleansed of their judgments, and through this power, the eyes of Zeir Anpin are bathed in milk. Fourth, the secret of the Nose, which creates satisfaction below, and through it prayer is received, as it is written, "And for My praise I will restrain [My anger] for you." Fifth, the secret of the Beard, whose entire existence is to nullify judgments and cancel them in thirteen different ways. 5R 10R 15R 20R 25R

The sixth rectification, which appears in physical form as the flowing locks of the beard, is the hair that covers the beard from the edge of the mouth to the underside of the mouth. It is called "desiring kindness" in the attributes "Who is a God like You," and in the attributes "God is compassionate" it is "and truth." This rectification is the connection of Netzach and Hod with Yesod, and through Netzach and Hod it passes to Malkhut.[3] Netzach desires to draw down kindness, and similarly in the attributes "abundant in kindness and truth," "abundant in kindness" is connected with "truth," because Netzach is connected with truth. Therefore, the prophets of truth 30R 35R

[1] This is a complex kabbalistic concept describing the inter-inclusion of divine attributes, where one sefirah (divine emanation) is contained within another. The text is describing how the power of judgment becomes 'rooted' or 'embedded' in higher divine attributes.

[2] In Kabbalah, the Hebrew letter Vav (ו) is visualized as a channel or conduit. The beard's hairs are seen as channels extending from the divine realm, each functioning as a conduit for divine energy.

[3] The text describes the flow of divine energy through the sefirot (divine emanations). Netzach (Victory/Eternity) and Hod (Splendor) are the seventh and eighth sefirot, which channel divine energy to Yesod (Foundation), and then to Malkhut (Kingdom), the lowest sefirah representing our physical world.

ותקון זה נקרא חסד של אמת
שעושים עם הנשמות דהיינו חסד
של אמת שעושים עם המתים
והם חסדים המושפעים להרפות
הדין כאשר הוא מתחזק ומבטלו
ואין נותן לו כח להתחזק. וזו
תהיה כוונת כל המטפלים במת
להמשיך מתקון חפץ חסד ממדות
אריך ובמדות זעיר ממדת ואמ״ת
להרפות כח הדינין המתגברים
בכח המות. ונושאי המטה הם
דוגמת כחות המתפשטות ממלאך
מיכאל כשהולך להקריב הנשמה
לפני מזבח ה׳ הטהור ונושא
אותה על כנפי רוח ומלאכי
צבאות ידודון ידודון לסייעה
וללוותה ולהעבירה דרך ע״ב
גשרי החסד המשפיעים מכחם
על מחנה מיכאל כהנא רבא.
וחוצבי קברות בחצר מות
התחתון לשם שמים הם דוגמת
האופנים המתקנים קבר עליון
בחצר מות עליון בעשיה רוחניות
ששם מדור הנפש כן בקבר יש
מדור לחלק תחתון מהנפש
הנפטר כאשר כתבנו למעלה
ועצמות אלישע יוכיחו שאחר
כמה שנים החיו האיש שהשליכו
בקברו. וגם שאין למדים ממעשה
נסים מ״מ הוכחה יש ששוכב
על העצמות שבקבר לעולם
חיות מה ועל ידו הוא החלוץ
בעצמות שפי׳ יזיין ידשן וכו׳.
עוד חוצבי הקבר הם לדוגמת
אותם המלאכים המשמשים את
הגן ואותם הצדיקים אשר שם
המתקנים מדורות הצדיק׳
המזומנים ליכנם שם ומכינים
מקום כבודם בגן עדן בכמה
מיני בוסמין וחופות כנראה
ממה שהובא בזהר פ׳ ויחי
שאמר אבוה לר׳ יצחק שהיה
ג׳ ימים שהצדיקים ומלאכי

are called "prophets of truth" (in Aramaic), and it cancels judgments through drawing down kindnesses, and kindness depends on this root. 40R

This rectification is called "true kindness" (chesed shel emet) that is done with souls, namely, the true kindness that is done with the dead. These are kindnesses that are bestowed to weaken judgment when it strengthens, nullifying it and not allowing it to gain strength. This should be the intention of all who attend to the deceased—to draw from the rectification of "desiring kindness" from the attributes of Arich Anpin, and from the attributes of Zeir Anpin, from the attribute of "and truth," to weaken the power of judgments that intensify through the power of death. 45R 50R

Those who carry the bier resemble the forces that extend from the angel Michael when he goes to offer the soul before God's pure altar, bearing it on wings of spirit. The angels of hosts hasten to assist, accompany, and guide it through the seventy-two bridges of kindness,[1] which channel their power through Michael's camp, the great priest. 55R

Those who dig graves in the lower court of death for the sake of Heaven resemble the Ophanim angels who prepare the upper grave in the upper court of death in the spiritual realm of Asiyah, where the soul dwells.[2] Similarly, in the grave there is a dwelling place for the lower part of the departed soul, as we have written above. The bones of Elisha prove this, for after many years they revived the man who was cast into his grave. Even though we do not derive teachings from miraculous events, there is evidence that something vital always rests upon the bones in the grave, and through it comes the invigoration of the bones, as is explained. 60R 65R 70R

Furthermore, those who dig the grave resemble those angels who serve in the Garden and those righteous ones who are there, who prepare the dwelling places of the righteous who are destined to enter there. They prepare a place of honor for them in the Garden of Eden with various kinds of fragrances and canopies, as is evident from what is brought in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, where it states that the father said to Rabbi Yitzchak that for three days the 75R 80R

[1] This refers to the 72-letter divine name in Kabbalah, derived from three verses in Exodus 14:19-21. Each verse contains 72 letters, and when arranged in a specific pattern, they form 72 three-letter names of God, each representing a channel or 'bridge' of divine mercy.

[2] In Kabbalah, Asiyah is the lowest of four spiritual worlds (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah). While Asiyah corresponds most closely to our physical world, it also has a spiritual counterpart where souls may dwell after death.

הגן היו מכינים לו מקום בג״ע ומדור עילאה שהיו מתקנים לרשב״י וכמה כוין פתיחין ליה לאנהרא מזיוא עילאה. ואפילו בצדיקים שבדורותינו נראה באר היטב ממה שהובטח למהרר״י קארו באשר הבאנו בחלק א׳. ולדברים אלו ישימו לבם חוצבי קברות ומלוי המתים ובזה יכירו וידעו כמה רב גובריהו במעשה ההוא ויקדשו רוחם ונפשם בהתעסק במלאכת שמים ומזה יש כמה בחינות בכל מעשה הקדושה וא״א לכוין הכל בכתב ישמע חכם ויבין: [i]

righteous and the angels of the Garden were preparing a place for him in the Garden of Eden, as well as the supernal dwelling that they were preparing for Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, with many openings made for him to be illuminated by the supernal radiance. 85R

Even regarding the righteous of our generations, this is clearly seen from what was promised to Rabbi Joseph Karo, as we brought in Part One. Those who dig graves and accompany the dead should take these matters to heart, and through this they will recognize and know how great their power is in that act. They should sanctify their spirit and soul by engaging in heavenly work. There are many aspects to every act of holiness, and it is impossible to convey everything in writing—let the wise hear and understand. 90R 95R

פרק י״ז

השבע הקפות שנוהגים בקצת מקומות לעשות למת בבית הקברות נ״ל ע״ד כי הוא תקון גדול להבריח מעליו רוחות רעות כי סביבו רשעים יתהלכון שהם כמדורין סביב משכן הנער מטטרו״ן. ולהיות צורה הנכבדת זו כלי שנשתמש בו קדש וירד ממדרגתו בנסוע ממנו הנשמה

Chapter 17

The seven circuits (hakafot) that are customary in some places to perform for the deceased in the cemetery appear to me to be a great correction to drive away evil spirits,[1] for "the wicked walk around" (Psalms 12:9) who are like chambers surrounding the dwelling of the youth Metatron.[A] Since this honored form was a vessel used for holiness[B] and has descended from its level when the holy soul departed from it, yet traces of holiness remain 5R

[A] Or: "the tabernacle of the lad Metatron" — The term 'mishkan' (משכן) literally means 'tabernacle' or 'dwelling place' and is often used in kabbalistic texts to refer to celestial structures. 'Na'ar' (נער) can be translated as either 'youth' or 'lad', both being titles for the angel Metatron in kabbalistic literature.

[B] Or: "this honored form was a vessel in which sanctity dwelled" — The phrase describes the human body as having been a container for sacred content (the soul). This alternative translation emphasizes the dwelling aspect rather than the instrumental aspect.

[1] The term 'lehavriach' (להבריח) has the connotation of actively causing the spirits to flee or be driven away, rather than merely repelling them passively.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The author cites this passage to establish that the work of preparing graves has a celestial parallel, where angels and righteous souls prepare dwelling places in the Garden of Eden for the newly deceased. | Cf. 2 Kings 13:21 — The author uses this biblical example to argue that some spiritual vitality remains connected to human remains even long after death, supporting his larger point about the spiritual significance of proper burial practices. | Cf. Exodus 34:6-7 — The text refers to the 'thirteen rectifications of the beard' which correspond to these thirteen divine attributes. This establishes that proper burial practices connect to these channels of divine mercy. | Cf. Idra Rabba and Idra Zuta (sections of the Zohar) — The author is drawing on this kabbalistic framework to explain how those who handle the dead are actually participating in cosmic processes that affect the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part One — The author refers back to his own work, creating continuity and reinforcing the application of these mystical principles to recent historical figures.

הקדושה מחמת שירי קדושה הנשאר שם הרוחות מבקשים ליהנות ממנו. ולהיות צורת האשה אפי׳ בחייה מוכנת לשרות עליה כחות הטומאה כי הויית נפשה היא מן כח השמאלי[i] ולכן כתיב מכשפה לא תחיה[ii] ואמרו כי דבר הכתוב בהוה לכן תכף למיתת נשים קבורה כי בגופה תרמוש חיתו יער. ובסוד ההקפות שהם דוגמת המחול שעתיד הקב״ה לעשות לצדיקים בג״ע כי אז תשמח בתולת ישראל במחול ההוא בסוד אני ראשון ואני אחרון[iii] החצונים תובעי דין מסתלקים מהמדורין ואינם נותנים עוד קול קטרוגם בבית ה׳ כי כשאור המלאכים קדושים הרצים עליונים יוצאים שם במדורין דחופים בדבר ה׳ אין פורץ ונדחים משם לסוף פתח לבנת הספיר בחלון ששם הנקראת נוקבא דתהומא רבה. וזה סוד הקפת יריחו[iv] להיותה

there,[1] the spirits seek to derive benefit from it. And since a woman's form, even during her lifetime, is susceptible to impure forces resting upon her because her soul's existence comes from the left side power,[2] therefore it is written "You shall not allow a sorceress to live" (Exodus 22:17), and they said that the Torah speaks of what commonly occurs, thus immediately after women die, burial is required, for in her body "the beasts of the forest prowl" (Psalms 104:20). 10R 15R

The secret of these circuits is that they are like the dance that the Holy One, blessed be He, will make for the righteous in the Garden of Eden, for then "the virgin of Israel will rejoice in that dance" (Jeremiah 31:12). Through the mystery of "I am the first and I am the last" (Isaiah 44:6), the external forces that demand judgment[A] withdraw from their chambers and no longer raise their accusatory voices in the house of the Lord. For when the light of the holy angels, the supernal runners, emerges there in those chambers, hastened by the word of the Lord, none can breach, and they are pushed from there to the edge of the opening of the sapphire brick, to the window that is called the opening of the great 20R 25R 30R

[A] Or: "the external entities that seek to prosecute" — In kabbalistic literature, 'chitzonim' (החצונים) refers to negative spiritual entities outside the realm of holiness. The term 'tovei din' (תובעי דין) has legal connotations of prosecution or demanding judgment, so this alternative captures the prosecutorial role these entities play in the spiritual realm.

[1] The phrase 'shirei kedushah' (שירי קדושה) literally means 'remnants of holiness' and refers to the spiritual residue left in the body after the soul's departure. This concept is central to understanding why the body requires protection through ritual.

[2] In kabbalistic cosmology, the 'left side' (כח השמאלי) is associated with the divine attribute of Gevurah/Din (Judgment/Severity), in contrast to the 'right side' associated with Chesed (Loving-kindness). This attribution of the feminine to the left side reflects kabbalistic gender associations that see women as more connected to judgment forces.

[i] The reference to the 'left side power' reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the feminine aspects of creation are associated with the left side of the divine structure (sefirotic tree), which is connected to the attributes of judgment and limitation rather than the right side's mercy and expansion.

[ii] The text cites Exodus 22:17 ('You shall not allow a sorceress to live') and interprets it through a kabbalistic lens to explain the Torah's focus on female practitioners of sorcery as stemming from women's supposed greater susceptibility to impure spiritual forces due to their soul's origin from the 'left side.'

[iii] This phrase ('I am the first and I am the last') from Isaiah 44:6 is understood in Jewish mystical tradition as expressing God's encompassing presence before and after all of creation. In this context, it suggests that the divine presence established through the ritual circuits pushes away accusatory forces.

[iv] This connects the ritual practice of circling the deceased to the biblical narrative in Joshua 6, where the Israelites circled Jericho seven times before its walls fell. In both cases, the circuits are understood to have supernatural power to break down barriers, whether physical walls or spiritual impediments.

סוגרת למטה ומסוגרת למעלה
מכחות הטומאה בסוד ההקפות
עם השופרות המחרידים כל
עם הארץ ובכח קדושת הארון
אשר היתה מכלה אותם והיו
נמסים מפניה כמסוס נוסס כן
ההקפות בסוד שיר של פגעים
ושם מ״ב[i] שבתוקפו ובגבורתו
משבר הרים ומפרק סלעים
וחוצב להבות אש ובוער כתנור
לכל זדים ועושי רשעה יבושו
ויחתו מגבורתם כל הרוחות
אשר יחד יסולו דרכם סביב
הנפטר ופונים מקום לקדושים
הבאים ללוותו ומוליכים לפניו
צדקו. וא״כ כמה רב טובם ויפים
ממקומות שנוהגים אותם במקום
דליכא למיחש לאנצויי המרגילם
תבא עליו ברכה. ויש מקומות
שאחר צדוק הדין כשנושאים
אותו לקבר אומרים שיר של
פגעים ונכון הוא. סדר ההקפות
כפי הנמצא בדברי חכמים
ברחיצה הגדולה המיוחסת
להלל הזקן[ii] כבר באו בתחלת
הספר:[iii]

abyss.[A]

This is the secret of encircling Jericho, which was closed below and sealed above from impure forces through the mystery of the circuits with the shofars that terrified all the people of the land, and through the power of the sanctity of the Ark which consumed them. They melted before it like melting wax,[1] and so too these circuits, through the mystery of the "Song of Afflictions" (Psalm 91) and the 42-letter Name, which in its power and might shatters mountains, breaks apart rocks, hews flames of fire, and burns like a furnace against all the arrogant and evil-doers. They are ashamed and dismayed from their might—all the spirits that together clear their path around the deceased, making way for the holy ones who come to escort him and lead his righteousness before him.

Therefore, how great is their goodness and beauty! In places where they are practiced, in locations where there is no concern for quarreling,[2] may blessings come upon those who institute them. There are places where after reciting the Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment),[3] when they carry the deceased to the grave, they recite the "Song of Afflictions" (Psalm 91), and this is proper. The order of the circuits according to what is found in the words of the sages in the "Great

[A] Or: "the entrance of the sapphire pavement, to the aperture known as the opening of the great deep" — These are technical kabbalistic terms referring to specific celestial locations. 'Livnat hasapir' can be translated as 'sapphire pavement' (as in Exodus 24:10), and 'nukva d'tehoma rabba' literally means 'the female aspect of the great deep,' which is often rendered as 'the opening of the great abyss' in English translations of kabbalistic texts.

[1] The phrase 'k'mesos noses' (כמסוס נוסס) is difficult to translate precisely. It creates a powerful image of complete dissolution or melting away, emphasizing the total defeat of impure forces in the face of sacred power.

[2] The phrase 'd'leka l'meichash l'antzuyei' (דליכא למיחש לאנצויי) reflects a halakhic (Jewish legal) concern that certain ritual innovations might lead to communal discord. The author acknowledges this concern while still endorsing the practice when it doesn't cause controversy.

[3] This is a prayer recited at Jewish funerals affirming God's righteousness even in death. It begins with the words 'The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are justice' (Deuteronomy 32:4).

[i] The '42-letter Name' (Shem Mem-Bet) refers to a mystical divine name in Jewish Kabbalah, often derived from the first 42 letters of the creation account in Genesis or from an acrostic of the prayer 'Ana Bekoach.' It is considered particularly powerful for protection against harmful spiritual forces.

[ii] This refers to a ritual washing procedure for the deceased attributed to Hillel the Elder, a first-century BCE Jewish sage. The author indicates this procedure was detailed earlier in the book, showing how Ma'avar Yabok serves as a comprehensive guide to Jewish death rituals.

[iii] Cf. Psalms 12:9 — The author cites this verse to establish that wicked forces encircle and threaten the deceased, providing biblical grounding for the practice of protective circuits. | Cf. Joshua 6:1-20 — The author draws a parallel between the ritual circuits around the deceased and the biblical story of the Israelites encircling Jericho, suggesting that both practices serve to break down barriers

Washing" attributed to Hillel the Elder has already been presented at the beginning of the book.

פרק י״ח

אחר ההקפות ירימו ארגז המת מעל הארץ על זרועותיהם ויכוונו להעלותו על זרועות עולם כדכתיב ומתחת זרועות עולם[i] כי אחרי שמגמילות חסדים שעשו לו נעשה בסוד אמת והכניסוהו לתיבה בסוד נקוד׳ בהיכלה ממש[ii] ואז מתעלם בה״א אחרונה ושם נמתקו כחות בסוד הדין[iii] בסוד צדוק הדין והקדיש וההקפות בנזכר בסוף חלק ב׳ עתה בכח שם מ״ב שהזכירו ובקשו עליו רחמים בסוד שם זה העולה הנה הוא מוכן להעלותו לסוד זרועות עולם ומשם יסק ויעלה להסתתר ברום חביון

Chapter 18

After the circuits, they shall raise the coffin of the deceased from the ground onto their arms,[1] and they shall intend to elevate him upon the "arms of the world," as it is written: "And underneath are the everlasting arms." For after the acts of lovingkindness they have performed for him, he is transformed through the mystery of Truth,[2] and they have placed him in the ark in the true mystery of "a point within its palace." Then he becomes concealed within the final hei[3] [of the divine name], and there the forces are sweetened through the mystery of judgment, through the Justification of Judgment prayer, the Kaddish, and the circuits, as mentioned at the end of Part Two. Now, through the power of the 42-letter Name which they have invoked, and through which they have sought mercy for him,[A] behold, he is prepared

[A] Or: "Now, through the power of the 42-letter Name they have mentioned and through which they have beseeched mercy for him in the mystery of this elevated Name" — This alternative provides a more precise rendering of 'העולה' which can refer to the Name's elevated status or ascension power rather than just being 'invoked.'

[1] The text assumes knowledge of the preceding ritual of 'hakafot' (circuits) around the deceased's bier, which has just been described in the previous section.

[2] The Hebrew word 'אמת' (Truth) has special kabbalistic significance as it consists of the first, middle, and last letters of the Hebrew alphabet (alef, mem, tav), representing totality and perfection. Here it refers to the deceased's spiritual transformation through proper burial rites.

[3] In Kabbalah, the final hei of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) represents the divine feminine aspect (Shekhinah/Malkhut). This passage describes the soul's integration into this divine realm through proper burial.

(walls/impure forces) through sacred circumambulation. | Cf. Psalm 91 — The author refers to Psalm 91 by its rabbinic name 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons), which in rabbinic tradition was believed to have special protective powers against harmful spiritual forces, making it particularly appropriate for funeral contexts. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The technical terminology about 'nukva d'tehoma rabba' (the opening of the great abyss) draws from Zoharic cosmology, where this concept represents a location where negative forces are confined or pushed away from the realm of holiness. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section 1 — The author refers to an earlier section of his own book where the ritual of the seven circuits was detailed, showing the text's self-referential nature and indicating that this passage is providing additional theological justification for a practice already described elsewhere in the work.

[i] This refers to Deuteronomy 33:27, "The eternal God is your dwelling place, and underneath are the everlasting arms." In kabbalistic interpretation, these "arms" represent the divine attributes of Chesed (Loving-kindness) and Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) that support the cosmos.

[ii] A kabbalistic concept referring to the divine feminine (Malkhut/Shekhinah) as a point within the divine palace or temple. Here, it metaphorically describes the deceased as being integrated into the divine feminine realm.

[iii] "Sweetening of judgments" (המתקת הדינים) is a fundamental kabbalistic concept where harsh divine judgments are transformed or tempered through various spiritual processes, including proper ritual actions and prayers.

אשר עין לא ראתה והוא טמור וגניז במקום שאין העין שולט בו בו ומעלימים אותו בקברו. ובעת שמכניסים אותו שם יכוונו כנזכר למעלה בעפר שתחתיו ובעפר שנותנים עליו שהם רמז עפר העליון ועפר תחתון בסוד שני הוי״ן שבשם ובוא״ו שהוא רומז לצדיק שביניהם המתעדן מעדון עליון ותחתון וג״ע של מעלה מכוון לעפר עליון וג״ע שלמטה מכוון לעפר תחתון כמו שהגוף מוצא מנוח בשובו ליסודו לעפר הלזו כך הנשמה והרוח והנפש שלו מוצאים מנוחה בשוב כל אחד מהם למקורו המיוחד ומיועד לו והמבין שותא דרבנן דאמר הכל היה מן העפר ואפי׳ גלגל חמה ישכיל וידע כי דברי חכמים בדרבונות ועיין מזה בר״מ פ׳ צו דף ל״ד ע״ב. ויכוין במעשה הקבורה כנזכר למעלה להכניס נפשו למעלה בקבר עליון ונשמתו בסוד תלת עשר נהרי דאפרסמונא הנמשכים מי״ג תקוני דיקנא[i] כנרמז בפ׳ ויקבור אותו בגי כנזכר למעלה. עוד יכוין להצפין נשמתו בתוך י״ג חופות שבהם מתעדנים הצדיקים בג״ע על דרך שאמרו ברשב״י דהוא יתיב על תליסר תכתקי פיזא[ii] ועיין בזהר פ׳ תרומה דף קמ״ז ע״א. ויאמר כל א׳ פסוק והוא רחום וגו׳ ג׳ פעמים[iii] וזהו

to be elevated to the mystery of the "arms of the world," and from there he will ascend and rise to be hidden in the heights of concealment which no eye has seen, and he is hidden and stored in a place where the eye has no dominion, as they conceal him in his grave.

When they place him there, they should have in mind, as mentioned above, the symbolism of the earth beneath him and the earth they place upon him—these represent the upper earth and the lower earth,[A] corresponding to the two heis in the Divine Name, with the vav between them[1] representing the Righteous One who delights in both upper and lower pleasure. The upper Garden of Eden corresponds to the upper earth, and the lower Garden of Eden corresponds to the lower earth. Just as the body finds rest in returning to its elemental source in this earth, so too the neshamah, ruach, and nefesh find rest when each returns to its own particular source designated for it. One who understands the discourse of the sages who said, "Everything was from dust, even the sphere of the sun," will comprehend and know that the words of the sages are like goads. See Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Tzav, folio 34b.

One should focus during the burial, as mentioned above, on guiding his nefesh upward to the celestial grave and his neshamah into the thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil that flow from the thirteen configurations of the divine beard, as alluded to in the verse "And He buried him in the valley," as mentioned above. One should further intend to conceal his neshamah within the thirteen canopies in which the righteous delight in the Garden of Eden, as they said of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, that he sits upon

[A] Or: "they should focus their intention, as mentioned above, on the earth beneath him and the earth placed upon him, which symbolize the supernal earth and the terrestrial earth" — This translation better preserves the technical kabbalistic terminology distinguishing between upper/supernal and lower/terrestrial realms, which are important concepts in the cosmology being described.

[1] This refers to the structure of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), where the first hei represents Binah (Understanding), the vav represents Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), and the final hei represents Malkhut (Kingdom). The text is describing a cosmic correspondence between physical burial and divine structures.

[i] In Kabbalah, the thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil represent divine channels of blessing flowing from the thirteen attributes of divine mercy, often depicted as configurations of the "divine beard" (תיקוני דיקנא). This imagery appears frequently in the Zohar.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase describes Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai sitting on thirteen thrones of fine gold in the Garden of Eden, representing the highest spiritual attainment after death.

[iii] This refers to Psalm 78:38, "But He, being merciful, forgave their iniquity and did not destroy

ג״ח גדול למת להחליש ראשי
המשחית הנזכרים בפסוק הזה
ואם יאמרוהו כל הקהל ג״פ
בקול הנה מה טוב שהם ל״ט
55 תיבות כנודע ג״פ י״ג כנגד י״ג
מדות רחמים וי״ג גבולים פי׳
מיני יחוד שבשלשה מקומות
באצילות וכמו כן בבי״ע ובזה
מקילים מעליו כח המלקות
60 מחבוט הקבר ושאר דינים
ואח״כ יאמרו וסר עונך וחטאתך
תכופר. ונחך ה׳ תמיד וגו׳.
וישב עמי בנוה שלום וגו׳. ויהו
נועם ה׳ אלהינו עלינו ומעשה
65 ידינו כוננה עלינו וגו׳. וכוונתם
תהיה לבסם ולהחליש כחות
פולסי דנורא בכח מדת אמ״ת
וחפ״ץ חס״ד כאשר ביארנו
למעלה ולעורר הנעימות העליון
70 עליו על ידי החמשים שערים
המתפשטים מסוד עה״ב. ועיין
פ׳ בלק דף קמ״ה למה נדון
האדם אחר המות בז׳ עדנין
אשר יחלפון עלוהי ואיך דנים
75 האדם אחר מותו ובעת מותו.
ודין אחר המות מתבאר בפרטות
בפ׳ נשא דף קכ״ו. ולבך יהגה
אימה ותבין כי חולי הנשמה
בע״הב היא מחמת אהבתה לגוף
80 כדדרשו על פסוק כי חולת
אהבה אני.[i] וטעם כמה דינים
דמתדנא הנשמה והגוף הכל
הוא לטובתם שאין הקב״ה בא
בטרוניא עם בריותיו כי מבלי
85 תקון ומרוק אין מאכילין לו
לאדם מטוב מעשיו שא״א לאדם
לקבלו בנזכר למעלה שכל עקר
האושר אינו אלא ההתדבקות עם
קונו וזהו ונהנים מזיו שבינה
90 וכן כתיב והתהלכתי בתוככם

thirteen thrones of fine gold. See Zohar, Parashat Terumah, folio 147a.

Each person should recite the verse "And He, being merciful" three times. This is a great act of kindness for the deceased, weakening the heads of the destroyer mentioned in this verse. If the entire congregation recites it three times aloud, how good it is, for there are thirty-nine words, as is known—three times thirteen, corresponding to the thirteen attributes of mercy and the thirteen boundaries, meaning types of unification in the three realms of Atzilut, and likewise in Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah. In this way, they lighten the force of the beating of the grave and other judgments. 55R 60R

Afterward, they should say: "And your iniquity is taken away, and your sin is atoned for," "And the Lord will guide you continually," "And my people shall dwell in peaceful habitation," and "May the pleasantness of the Lord our God be upon us, and establish the work of our hands upon us." Their intention should be to sweeten and weaken the forces of fiery lashes through the power of the attributes of Truth and Desiring Kindness, as we have explained above, and to awaken the supernal pleasantness upon him through the fifty gates that extend from the mystery of the World to Come.[1] 65R 70R 75R

See Parashat Balak, folio 145, on why a person is judged after death during seven periods that pass over him, and how a person is judged after his death and at the time of his death. The judgment after death is explained in detail in Parashat Naso, folio 126. Let your heart meditate with awe, and understand that the soul's ailment in the World to Come stems from its love for the body, as they expounded on the verse, "For I am lovesick." 80R 85R

The reason for the many judgments that the soul and body undergo is entirely for their benefit, for the Holy One, blessed be He, does not deal tyrannically with His creatures. Without correction and purification, a person cannot be fed from the goodness of his 90R

[1] The "fifty gates" is a traditional kabbalistic concept referring to the highest levels of spiritual understanding, often associated with Binah (Understanding). The text suggests that proper burial rituals activate these divine channels of blessing.

them." The triple recitation of this verse is a common Jewish practice for invoking divine mercy and is believed to have protective powers.

[i] This is a creative interpretation of Song of Songs 2:5 ("For I am lovesick") to explain the soul's continued attachment to the body even after death. This kabbalistic reading transforms a love poem into a metaphysical statement about the soul's journey.

ואמרו אטייל עמכם בג״ע וכתיב
והיתה נפש אדוני צרורה בצרור
החיים את ה׳ אלהיך. ואמרו כל
זמן שאדם חי נפשו נתונה בידו
95 של הקב״ה דכתיב אשר בידו
נפש כל חי וכשמת נתונה באוצר
ואוצר זה הוא התכללותה בסוד
אוצרות ביצה ותפארת ומלכות
בסוד הבריאה יצירה עשיה
100 רוחנית אחרי שתקנה מעשיה
בעשיה גשמית ואם עקר האומר
הוא הדבקות עם ה׳ איך יהיה
לו כן והוא נפרד בעונותיו
שהפסיקו החבור שהיה לו עם
105 יוצרו בהשתלשלות חבור נפשו
ורוחו ונשמתו באופן שכל מעשה
הטוב אשר יעשה האדם יהיה
אושר אורות מעשים ההם עם
ה׳ אלהיו כמוס עמו יתברך עד
110 ירחץ יטהר מכל טומאתו אשר
הוא טמא לנפש על עונו כמ״ש על
אלישע אחר שלא נהנה מתורתו
עד שר״מ תלמידו הכניסו לצרוף
סיגו בגיהנם וכשמת עלה עשן
115 מקברו וכן לוי לא היו מכניסין
אותו לישיבה של מעלה על שלא
נהג כבוד לר׳ אפס.[i] ומעשים
כיוצא בזה בס״ה רבים. וא״כ
הנשמה חיה חיי עד מאמת חלייה
120 ויסוריה וכי הגוף וה״ה ביסורים
הבאים בעה״ז כי יאמר אדם הלא
על כי אין אלהי בקרבי מצאוני
הרעות האלה ובזה יפשפש
מעשיו אשר לעומת יסוריו ושב
125 ורפא לו באופן כי טוב לו חליו
מבריאתו כי בו יחיה את נפשו.

deeds,[1] for it is impossible for a person to receive it, as mentioned above. The essential happiness is none other than cleaving to one's Creator, and this is "enjoying the radiance of the Divine Presence." Thus it is written, "I will walk among you," and they said, "I will stroll with you in the Garden of Eden." And it is written, "May the soul of my lord be bound in the bond of life with the Lord your God." 95R

They said that as long as a person lives, his soul is placed in the hand of the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is written, "In whose hand is the soul of all living things." And when he dies, it is placed in a treasury. This treasury is its integration into the mystery of the treasuries of Netzach, Tiferet, and Malkhut,[2] in the mystery of spiritual Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah, after it has corrected its deeds in physical Asiyah. If the essential thing is cleaving to God, how can this be achieved when one is separated by his sins, which have interrupted the connection he had with his Creator through the chain of connection of his nefesh, ruach, and neshamah? Thus, all the good deeds that a person performs will result in the illumination of those deeds being stored with the Lord his God until he is washed and purified from all his impurity with which he has defiled his soul through his sin. 100R 105R 110R 115R

As they said of Elisha Acher, that he did not benefit from his Torah until his student Rabbi Meir brought him to refine his dross in Gehenna, and when he died, smoke rose from his grave. Similarly, Levi was not admitted to the celestial academy because he did not show proper respect to Rabbi Afes. There are many similar accounts in the Zohar. Thus, the soul lives eternal life from the truth of its illness and suffering,[A] and the body likewise with the sufferings that come in this world. For a person will say, "Is it 120R 125R

[A] Or: "Thus, the soul lives eternal life precisely through the authenticity of its illness and suffering" — The phrase 'מאמת חלייה' has a nuanced meaning where 'מאמת' can suggest that suffering itself becomes the instrument or verification of eternal life, not just its source.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that even righteous deeds require spiritual refinement before their reward can be fully received in the afterlife. The text presents suffering as a necessary purification process that enables spiritual fulfillment.

[2] These three divine attributes (sefirot) are understood in Kabbalah to correspond to different levels of soul experience after death. The text describes how the soul becomes integrated into these cosmic structures following physical death.

[i] This refers to a Talmudic account (Ketubbot 103b) where Levi was temporarily barred from the heavenly academy for disrespecting Rabbi Afes, illustrating how interpersonal conduct affects one's spiritual state after death.

ויש מקומות שאומרים כלם אחר ששמוהו בקברו אסיפת שלום תהיה אסיפתו ורביצת שלום תהיה רביצתו מחיצת שלום תהיה מחיצתו. שכיבת שלום תהיה שכיבתו. הנה מכון הנה מלון הנה מנוחה וכו׳. ויאמרו כל קהל עדתו יבא שלום יבא שלום יבא שלום ינוח על קבורתו. בלע המות לנצח ומחה ה׳ אלהים דמעה מעל כל פנים וחרפת עמו יסיר מעל כל הארץ כי ה׳ דבר. יחיו מתיך נבלתי יקומון הקיצו ורננו שוכני עפר כי טל אורות טליך וארץ רפאים תפיל. והוא רחום יכפר עון ולא ישחית והרבה להשיב אפו ולא יעיר כל חמתו. כל הנשמה תהלל יה הללויה. ברוך ה׳ אלהים אלהי ישראל וברוך שם כבודו לעולם וימלא כבודו את כל הארץ אמן ואמן:[i]

not because my God is not within me that these evils have found me?" Through this, he will examine his deeds in relation to his sufferings, and repent, and be healed. Therefore, his illness is better for him than his health, for through it he will give life to his soul.

There are places where they all say after they have placed him in his grave: "May his gathering be a gathering of peace,[1] may his resting be a resting of peace, may his partition be a partition of peace, may his lying down be a lying down of peace. Behold a place, behold a lodging, behold a rest," etc. And all the congregation of his assembly shall say: "May peace come, may peace come, may peace come and rest upon his burial. He has swallowed up death forever, and the Lord God will wipe away tears from all faces, and the reproach of His people He will take away from all the earth, for the Lord has spoken. Your dead shall live, my corpses shall arise; awake and sing, you who dwell in the dust, for your dew is a dew of light, and the earth shall cast out the departed." "And He, being merciful, forgives iniquity and does not destroy, and frequently turns away His anger and does not stir up all His wrath." "Let every soul praise the Lord, Hallelujah." "Blessed be the Lord God, the God of Israel, and blessed be His glorious name forever, and may His glory fill the whole earth, Amen and Amen."

[1] This prayer utilizes a series of Hebrew terms for rest that have double meanings: 'gathering' (אסיפה) refers both to death and to divine ingathering; 'resting place' (רביצה) suggests both physical repose and spiritual dwelling; 'partition' (מחיצה) indicates both the grave and spiritual categories in the afterlife.

[i] Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Tzav, folio 34b — This reference is cited to support the kabbalistic concept that all creation, even celestial bodies, originates from 'dust' or primordial matter. The reference reinforces the author's explanation of the symbolic correspondence between physical burial in earth and the soul's return to its spiritual source. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah, folio 147a — This reference describes Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai sitting upon thirteen thrones of fine gold in the Garden of Eden, which serves as a paradigm for the destiny of the righteous soul. The author uses this as a mystical template for understanding what happens to the neshamah after death. | Cf. Parashat Balak, folio 145 — This reference points to a Zoharic discussion about the seven periods of judgment that the soul undergoes after death. The author cites this to provide deeper context about post-mortem experiences without fully elaborating the details, directing the reader to consult the original source. | Cf. Parashat Naso, folio 126 — This reference directs readers to a detailed explanation in the Zohar about the judgment process after death. The author cites this as a resource for understanding the complex system of post-mortem judgment that forms the theological backdrop for the burial rituals being described. | Cf. For I am lovesick (Song of Songs 2:5) — The author creatively interprets this verse from Song of Songs to explain the soul's attachment to the body even after death. In kabbalistic thought, this 'lovesickness' represents the soul's continued connection to physical existence that may impede its spiritual elevation, requiring purification processes after death.

פרק י״ט

Chapter 19

אין לישראל גומלי חסדים העוסקים בצרכי המת להתפלא ולומר איך נוכל אנחנו לסדר ולכוין העניינים אלו עם הפסוקים כי הכל הולך אל המחשבה טובה. והאדם עובד במעט והקב״ה עוזרו ותומכו ברב.[i] אדם מיחד ואינו יודע לגמור הענין והעזר האלהי סומכו וכוננו וזהו נקרא שרוי שבינה במעשה האדם. כדפירש בזהר על מעשה ידינו כוננהו[ii] כדלקמן וכן אמרו פתחו לי פתח כחודה של מחט ואני אפתח לכם[iii] וכו׳. וכל מלאכת הקדש נעשית מאליה ודי לאדם להתחיל בה כי ה׳ יגמור על ידו כדכתיב ויכולו השמים והארץ וכן כתיב בעבודת אהל מועד ותכל מעצמה ובמקדש כתיב והבית בהבנותו ואם על העצים ועל האבנים לפי שהיו עתידים להתקדש נאמר כך כ״ש לגוף שהיה נרתק של קדושה. ודי שהגדול מאותם המתעסקים בו הוא יטול המשרה על שכמו לסדר דבריו ועסקיו של הנפטר יהיה רבו או חבירו או תלמידו ואחריו כל אדם ימשוך וכאשר יסדר ויאמר הוא כן יענו ויעשו אחריו דבתר רישא גופא אזיל. ואמרו בפ׳ פקודי דף רכ״ה שכל מקום ששלט צד הקדושה סטרא אחרא לא יכיל דדחייא לה מאתרה בכל מה שהוא עושה בנגדו כמו שפירשנו למעלה וכ״ש גוף תשמיש קדושה ועוד

The Jewish members of charitable burial societies who attend to the needs of the deceased should not be astonished and say, "How can we properly arrange and direct these matters with the verses?" For everything depends on good intention. A person works 5R
with little, and the Holy One, blessed be He, helps and supports abundantly. When one attempts to unify but does not know how to complete the matter, divine assistance supports and establishes them—
this is what is meant by "the Divine Presence dwells 10R
in a person's actions." As explained in the Zohar regarding "establish the work of our hands," as will be discussed later, and as they said, "Open for Me an opening as narrow as the eye of a needle, and I will
open for you," etc. All sacred work is accomplished 15R
of its own accord, and it is enough for a person to merely begin it, for the Lord will complete it through them, as it is written, "And the heavens and earth were completed," and similarly regarding the service
of the Tent of Meeting, "and it was completed by 20R
itself," and regarding the Temple it is written, "and the house, in its being built." If this was said about wood and stones because they were destined for sanctification, how much more so for the body, which was
a vessel of holiness.[1] 25R

It is sufficient that the most distinguished among those attending to the deceased take upon himself the responsibility to arrange the words and affairs of the departed, whether he was his teacher, colleague,
or student, and everyone else will follow his lead. As 30R
he arranges and speaks, so will they respond and act after him, for "the body follows the head." And they said in Parashat Pekudei, page 225, that wherever the side of holiness dominates, the Other Side cannot
prevail, for it is driven from its place by everything 35R
done against it, as we explained above. This is especially true for a body that was a vessel of holiness,

[1] The text emphasizes the sanctity of the human body that performed commandments during life, suggesting it retains spiritual significance even after death.

[i] This reflects the rabbinic concept that God completes human spiritual efforts that are begun with sincere intention, even when the person lacks complete knowledge.

[ii] This is a reference to Psalm 90:17, which is often interpreted as a prayer that God will establish human efforts. In this context, it means that divine support completes human attempts at proper ritual performance.

[iii] This is a famous rabbinic saying from Midrash Song of Songs Rabbah 5:2, expressing that God responds disproportionately to even small human spiritual initiatives.

קדש אבריו עצמם בעשיית
המצות ועוד יש בו חיות מה
40 כי ודאי זכותו בדאי לסייע
המתעסקים בו שיכוונו מעשיהם
כראוי לו והועד לפני כי תלמידי
המקובל אשכנזי צוק"ל[i] בשעה
שרצו להטבילו אחר מותו נשמט
45 גופו מתחת ידם ונשקע במים
ואחר כך צף על פני המים מעצמו
וגם שאין למדים מסוד קדושים
אלו דהוה חמי מראות עליונות
כדאמרו דחמא עמודא דנורא
50 דאוזיף הגאון קורדואיר"ו
לקבורתו[ii] מכל מקום כל אחד
לפי מדרגתו וזכותו יסייע
במתעסקים בו. וקודם צאתם
מבית הקברות ירחצו ידיהם.
55 מלבד טעם הנכתב במדרש שהוא
להבריח הרוחות השוכנות על
הידים[iii] בפרט מהטעם שכתבנו.
עוד הוא רמז כי ידינו לא
שפכו את הדם הזה[iv] לומר שלא
60 מנענו ממנו צרכיו ובקורו בעת
חליו. ויש שאומרים פסוק כפר
לעמך ישראל וגו' ויכוין ג"כ
לעורר אחר קבורת המת סוד
הרחמים בכל עשרה שליטים
65 עליונים[v] ולבסם כחות שנתלבשו
בדין ובזה יוסר בקצת חירוף

whose very limbs were sanctified through the performance of commandments, and which still contains some vitality. Certainly, the deceased's merit is sufficient to assist those attending to him so that they direct their actions appropriately for him. 40R

It was testified before me that when the disciples of the German Kabbalist of blessed memory wanted to immerse his body after death, it slipped from their hands and sank in the water, and afterward floated to the surface by itself.[A] Even though we do not derive teachings from the mysteries of these holy ones who beheld supernal visions—as they said that he saw a pillar of fire that accompanied the Gaon Cordovero to his burial—nevertheless, each person according to his level and merit will assist those who attend to him. 45R 50R

Before leaving the cemetery, they should wash their hands. Besides the reason written in the Midrash, which is to drive away the spirits that dwell on the hands,[1] particularly for the reason we have written, it is also an allusion to "our hands have not shed this blood," meaning that we did not withhold from him his needs and visits during his illness.[B] Some say the verse, "Atone for Your people Israel," etc., and one should also intend to arouse, after the burial of the deceased, the mystery of mercy in all ten supernal rulers and to sweeten the forces that are clothed in judgment. This will somewhat remove the reproach of the lower rulers 55R 60R 65R

[A] Or: "his body slipped from beneath their hands and sank into the water, then afterward rose to the water's surface by itself" — This more literal translation better preserves the physical imagery of the miraculous event, where the body first sinks completely and then rises without human assistance.

[B] Or: "declaring that we did not withhold from him his needs nor neglect to visit him during his illness" — This alternate more explicitly connects to the ethical obligation of visiting the sick (bikur cholim), which is an important theme throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] In Jewish mystical thought, negative spiritual forces were believed to attach themselves to a person's hands in a cemetery, which is one reason for the ritual washing upon leaving.

[i] This refers to a German kabbalist whose body reportedly exhibited supernatural properties during its tahara (ritual washing). Such stories were common in Jewish mystical circles to demonstrate the continued sanctity of a righteous person's body after death.

[ii] This refers to a miraculous pillar of fire that allegedly accompanied Rabbi Moses Cordovero (a prominent 16th-century kabbalist from Safed) to his burial. Such stories emphasized the divine approval of great scholars.

[iii] This reflects the belief that harmful spirits cling to the hands after visiting a cemetery, necessitating ritual washing before re-entering inhabited areas.

[iv] This alludes to Deuteronomy 21:7, where the elders declare their innocence regarding an unsolved murder. Here it metaphorically means the mourners did not neglect the deceased during life.

[v] This refers to the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah, which are often understood as "rulers" governing different aspects of divine influence.

השליטים תחתונים להכות הגוף בקבר וזה יהיה על דרך ויאמר למלאך המשחית די. עוד זה תהיה הערה לאדם שבכל עת יהיו בגדיו לבנים ויקדש עצמו מלמטה כי המות בכל עת ישלח חצו וברקו. ובנטילת ידיהם יאמר פסוק תפול עליהם אימתה ופחד בגדול זרועך ידמו כאבן עד יעבור עמך ה׳ עד יעבור עם זו קנית. והתקדשתם והייתם קדושים כי קדוש אני ה׳ אלהיכם. ועיין בזהר פ׳ נשא מסוד רחיצת ידים. ועל פי מה שכתוב בזהר על אותו צורבא מדרבנן שאמר רבי אלעזר ברכאן דאבא אצטריכו הכא ופעם אחת מצאו ר״ש בן יוחאי שהיה נוטל ידיו בשופע והתפלל עליו ואמר רבון כל העולמים מלא ידיו מברכותיך ומן היום ההוא והלאה נתעשר. על פי הדברים האלה הרגלתי עצמי לומר בכל פעם שאני נוטל ידי לסעודה רבון כל העולמים מלא ידי מברכותיך ומברכותיך יבורך בית עבדך לעולם ברכנו אבינו כלנו כאחד באור פניך כי בשעת המעשה התפלה נשמעת ובפרט בעת התעוררות רחמים ברחיצה וכן א״ר חסדא אנא משאי וכו׳ ונ״ל שגם כן ברחיצת ידים מדי צאתו מבית הקברות טוב לומר זה להתפלל על הנפטר ולומר מלא ידיו מברכותיך וידיו יהיה מלשון מקום בהתפלל לה׳ יחננהו מאוצר של חסד וחנינה וימלא מקומו בג״ע עליון ותחתון ובחצר מות מברכות פיהו משפע מימי החסד הנוזלים ומלבינים

who strike the body in the grave, in the manner of "and He said to the destroying angel, 'Enough.'" This is also a reminder for a person that at all times his garments should be white and he should sanctify himself from below, for death sends forth its arrow and lightning at any time.

When washing their hands, one should recite the verse: "Terror and dread fall upon them; through the greatness of Your arm they become still as a stone; until Your people pass over, O Lord, until the people whom You have purchased pass over." "And you shall sanctify yourselves and be holy, for I am the Lord your God." See the Zohar, Parashat Naso, regarding the mystery of hand washing. And according to what is written in the Zohar about that young scholar to whom Rabbi Eleazar said, "My father's blessings are needed here," and once Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai found him washing his hands abundantly and prayed for him, saying, "Master of all worlds, fill his hands with Your blessings,"[1] and from that day onward he became wealthy.

Based on these words, I have accustomed myself to say each time I wash my hands for a meal: "Master of all worlds, fill my hands with Your blessings, and from Your blessings may the house of Your servant be blessed forever.[2] Bless us, our Father, all of us as one, with the light of Your countenance," for at the time of the action, prayer is heard, especially at a time of arousal of mercy during washing. And so said Rabbi Hisda, "I wash," etc. And it seems to me that also when washing hands upon leaving the cemetery, it is good to say this, to pray for the departed and say, "Fill his hands with Your blessings"—where "his hands" should be understood as "his place," praying that the Lord grant him favor from the treasury of kindness and grace,[3] and fill his place in the upper and lower Garden of Eden and in the court of death with the blessings of His mouth, from the abundance of flowing waters of kindness that whiten the sins of His people Israel[4] with kindness and mercy. It is good to pour water over one's hands three times.

[1]The author adapts a prayer originally used for the living to benefit the deceased, reflecting the Jewish belief that actions by the living can assist souls in the afterlife.

[2]The ritual washing after leaving the cemetery becomes an opportunity not only to cleanse oneself from death impurity but also to generate blessings for both the deceased and the living.

[3]The hand washing ritual becomes an opportunity to pray for the deceased's soul, reflecting the belief that actions of the living can benefit the dead.

[4]The metaphor of water "whitening" sins reflects the Jewish concept of spiritual purification, where ritual actions have cosmic significance beyond their physical performance.

עונות עמו ישראל בחסד
וברחמים וטוב לשפוך המים
110 על ידיו ג״פ. ולרוב הטעמים
שכתבנו בנ״י זו טוב שלא לנגב
ידיו במפה ועוד כי בזה מראה
שאינו מסיח דעתו מן האבל
ואינו משליך אחרי גוו זכרון יום
115 המות וכבר כתבנו מזה בח״ב.
והמנחם האבל בעי ליסדא מלין
בקדמיתא[i] דהא חברייא דאיוב
הוו אמרי מלי קשוט אבל לנחמא
ליה לא בגין דבעי מלין דיודי
120 עלייהו וכדין יקבל עליה דינא
ויודי לאלהא קדישא כדעבד
אליהו. זה לשון הזהר פ׳ קרח
דף קע״ו. ויודיע אליו שאין
לבריה כלום אצל בוראו שהרי
125 משה רבן של כל הנביאים לא
בא אלא בלשון תחנונים שנאמר
ואתחנן אל ה׳ כדאמרי׳ שם
במדרש. והמנחם הוא במדרגת
מדת המשפט הממתק האף וזהו
130 יסרני ה׳ אך במשפט אל באפך
פן תמיטני וכשהשפע ממדת
המשפט בא למלכות אז היא
מתטהרת מדיניה ומתנחמת
מתגבורת הדין שהגבירו עליה
135 עונות התחתונים. ולכן אומרים
לאבלים מן השמים תנוחמו וכן
לשון המשנה בסנהדרין תתנחמו
מן השמים ועקר הנחמה הוא
שיצדק דין שמים בלב האבל
140 עד שבפיו יודה למלך המשפט
ויברך על הרעה מעין הטובה
שאז יזכה למה שאמר הנביא

For most of the reasons we have written regarding this hand washing, it is good not to dry one's hands with a cloth.[1] Additionally, this shows that one is not diverting attention from mourning and not casting behind one's back the remembrance of the day of death, as we have already written in Part 2. And one who comforts the mourner should establish words initially, for the companions of Job spoke words of truth but did not comfort him, because one needs words that he will acknowledge, and then he will accept the judgment upon himself and acknowledge the Holy God, as Elijah did. This is the language of the Zohar, Parashat Korach, page 176. 110R 115R 120R

One should inform the mourner that no creature has any claim against its Creator, for even Moses, the master of all prophets, came only with language of supplication, as it is said, "And I beseeched the Lord," as stated there in the Midrash. The comforter functions at the level of the attribute of justice that sweetens anger, and this is "The Lord has chastened me, but in justice, not in anger, lest You diminish me."[A] And when the flow from the attribute of justice comes to Malkhut (Kingdom), then it is purified from its judgments and is comforted from the intensity of judgment that the sins of those below have strengthened against it. 125R 130R

Therefore, we say to mourners, "May you be comforted from Heaven,"[2] and so is the language of the Mishnah in Sanhedrin, "May you be comforted from Heaven." The essence of consolation is that the mourner justify Heaven's judgment in his heart, to the point that with his mouth he acknowledges the King of Judgment and blesses for the bad in the manner of the good.[3] Then he will merit what the prophet said, "For she has received from the 135R 140R

[A] Or: "Chasten me, O LORD, but with justice—not in Your anger, lest You reduce me to nothing" — This alternate translation more directly reflects the biblical quotation from Jeremiah 10:24 and better conveys the contrast between tempering justice with measured correction versus destructive anger.

[1] The author recommends allowing the hands to air dry after cemetery hand washing as a way of maintaining mindfulness of mortality rather than quickly returning to normal activities.

[2] This traditional Hebrew expression of consolation (מן השמים תנוחמו) emphasizes that true comfort comes from divine sources rather than human words alone.

[3] This refers to the rabbinic requirement to bless God for bad tidings as one would for good news (Mishnah Berakhot 9:5), showing complete acceptance of divine judgment.

[i] This Zoharic teaching instructs comforters to establish words that will help the mourner acknowledge and accept divine judgment, unlike Job's companions who failed to comfort him effectively.

כי לקחה מיד ה׳ כפלים בכל חטאתיה ירצה כי ישראל יקבלו נחמות כפלים מחטאתיהם אחד על כי יעשו תשובה מאהבה. וב׳ על קבלת היסורין מאהבה וכן צריך האבל לקיים בעצמו. כי יזכה לנחמות כפלים והמנחמים יזכירו ויזהירו על זה ולכן אמרו דנחמתא דבבלאי גידופא הוא[i] כיון שלא היו משתדלים עם האבל שיצדיק עליו דין שמים וכמו שנראה מדברים שנחמו חכמי ישראל לר׳ ישמעאל:[ii]

hand of the Lord double for all her sins,"[1] meaning that Israel will receive double consolation for their sins: first, for repenting out of love, and second, for accepting suffering with love. And so must the mourner fulfill within himself, for he will merit double consolation. Those who comfort should remind and caution about this. Therefore, they said that the Babylonian form of consolation is offensive, since they did not endeavor with the mourner to justify Heaven's judgment upon himself, as is evident from the words with which the sages of Israel comforted Rabbi Ishmael.

פרק כ׳

Chapter 20

כתוב בספר הלבוש ותולשין עשבים עם עפרן ואומרים זכור כי עפר אנחנו למען יזכור יום מיתתו ואנו אומרים פסוקים ועתה ה׳ אבינו אתה וגו׳ ויש אומרים שהוא רמז לתחיית המתים[iii] על דרך ויציצו מעיר כעשב הארץ וכבר כתבנו הנראה לנו בזה למעלה בחלק ב׳ וזורקים אותם על ראשיהם דרך צער על דרך ויזרקו עפר על ראשיהם השמימה. ונ״ל שיהיה להורות כי המתים בתחייה יתעלו בגוף טהור וזך הרבה למעלה מחומר הלז ע״י הטל

It is written in the book of Levush that one plucks grass along with its soil[2] and says "Remember that we are dust," so that one may remember the day of death. And we recite verses, "And now, O LORD, You are our Father, etc." Some say that this is an allusion to the resurrection of the dead, as it is written, "They shall blossom from the city like the grass of the earth." We have already written what appears to us regarding this above in Part 2. And they throw [the grass] upon their heads as a sign of grief, in the manner of "They threw dust upon their heads toward heaven." It seems to me that this is to indicate that in the resurrection, the dead will be elevated with a pure and refined body, far above this material substance, through the supernal dew

[1] This refers to Isaiah 40:2. The author interprets this verse as indicating that suffering accepted with love combined with repentance out of love creates double consolation.

[2] This refers to a Jewish cemetery custom where people pull up small tufts of grass before leaving the cemetery. The text explains multiple layers of meaning behind this seemingly simple ritual.

[i] The text criticizes the Babylonian form of consolation as offensive because it failed to help mourners justify and accept divine judgment, which is considered the true essence of comfort.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part 2 — The author refers to Part 2 (ח״ב) of his own work where he previously discussed aspects of washing hands after leaving a cemetery. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei, p. 225 — The author cites the Zohar to explain that the side of holiness can repel impure forces, reinforcing the idea that the sanctified body of a righteous person assists those preparing it for burial. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Naso — The author directs readers to the Zohar's discussion of hand washing rituals, which provides mystical explanations for the practice of washing hands after visiting a cemetery. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Korach, p. 176 — The author quotes the Zohar regarding proper methods of comforting mourners, emphasizing the importance of helping mourners accept divine judgment. | Cf. Talmud, Sanhedrin — The author cites the Mishnah in Sanhedrin to support the traditional consolation formula 'May you be comforted from Heaven.'

[iii] The author presents two interpretations of the cemetery ritual of plucking grass: as a reminder of mortality ('we are dust') and as a symbol of resurrection ('blossom like grass from the city'). This dual symbolism reflects the Jewish understanding of death as both an end and a beginning.

עליון המוכן להם שהוא שפע
יו״ד ה״א וא״ו בגימטרי״א
ט״ל[i] כנודע כנדרש במדרש
הנעלם בפ׳ וירא בדרוש מחשע
טפין הנוטפים מגנתא עוד מזה
בפ׳ חיי שרה באורך וכבר
כתבנו מזה למעלה במאמר
ראשון. בצאתם אומרים ויהי
נועם יושב בסתר עליון להבריח
הרוחות ויש שיושבין ז׳ פעמים
להבריח מהם הרוחות המלוות
את המת כדאמרן לעיל על פסוק
ונפשותיכן לפורחות ובכל עת
שהוא יושב בורחות ממנו עיין
הטעם שם ויש שיושבין ג״פ לבד
נגד ג׳ מיני מזיקים שכתבנו
למעלה וכן נגד ג׳ כתות של
מלאכי חבלה. אך טוב לישב ז׳
פעמים ובפעם ראשון יאמר ויהי
נועם יושב בסתר עד ונגע לא
יקרב באהלך. וגם יאמר מלת
כי שבראש פסוק כי מלאכיו
ואח״כ ישב במקום אחר ויאמר
ויהי נועם עד כי מלאכיו ופעם
השלישי עד כי מלאכיו יצוה
וכן עד דרכיך וישלים בפעם
השביעי כל המזמור ונ״ל טעם
לישיבת שבעה פעמים כי אמרו
שהקליפות וסטרא אחרא מהם
ששה כתות וכלם כאחד נקראים
נגעי בני אדם ור״ת למפרע
אב״ן[ii] כלומר שהם ע״י אבן
הראשה שהוא היצה״ר הוא השטן
וכלם רמוזים בפסוק לא תאונה
אליך רעה שהם בחות נקביות
ונגע לא יקרב באהלך אלו נגעי
בני אדם ע״כ אמרתי שטוב לומר
פסוק זה בלבתו לבקר החולה

prepared for them, which is the divine flow of Yod-Hei-Vav, whose numerical value equals "tal" (dew) as is known, as expounded in the Hidden Midrash on Parashat Vayera in the discourse about the nine drops that drip from the garden. More on this appears at length in Parashat Chayei Sarah, and we have already written about this above in the first discourse. 20R

Upon leaving [the cemetery], they recite "May the pleasantness" and "He who dwells in the secret place of the Most High" to drive away harmful spirits. Some sit seven times[1] to drive away the spirits that accompany the dead, as we stated above regarding the verse "and your souls to fluttering [spirits]," for whenever one sits, they flee from him. See the reason there. Some sit only three times, corresponding to the three types of harmful entities we wrote about above, and also corresponding to the three groups of destructive angels. However, it is good to sit seven times, and the first time one should recite "May the pleasantness" and "He who dwells in the secret place" until "nor shall any plague come near your dwelling." One should also say the word "For" at the beginning of the verse "For He shall command His angels," and afterward sit in another place and recite "May the pleasantness" until "For He shall command His angels," and the third time until "For He shall command His angels concerning you," and so on until "in all your ways," completing the entire psalm on the seventh time. 25R 30R 35R 40R 45R

It seems to me that the reason for sitting seven times is because they said that there are six groups of negative forces and the Other Side, and together they are all called "afflictions of the sons of man," the reverse acronym of which spells "even" (stone), meaning that they operate through the cornerstone, which is the evil inclination, which is Satan. They are all alluded to in the verse "No evil shall befall you," 50R

[1] This describes the practice of repeatedly sitting and standing seven times when leaving a cemetery as spiritual protection. The custom is called 'sheva yeshivot' (seven sittings) and is still practiced in some Jewish communities today.

[i] The author employs gematria (Hebrew numerology) to connect the divine letters Yod-Hei-Vav (יו״ד ה״א וא״ו) with the Hebrew word for dew (ט״ל/tal), both having the numerical value of 39. This connects the resurrection of the dead with the 'dew' that will revive them, based on Isaiah 26:19.

[ii] The author identifies that the reverse acronym of 'afflictions of the sons of man' (נגעי בני אדם) spells 'even' (אב״ן/stone), symbolizing the evil inclination as a 'cornerstone' of negative spiritual forces. This demonstrates the kabbalistic practice of finding spiritual meanings in word structures and letter combinations.

וכלם הם פורחות ומסתלקות ע״י
55 שיר של פגעים ועקרו עד כי אתה
ה׳ מחסי שבו ששים תיבות נגד
הנה מטתו שלשלמה שבו ששים
אותיות ובו קדשו ירושלים בימי
עזרא כדכתב הר״ן והם סובבים
60 האדם כשמוצאים בו עילה ליאחז
בו וכ״ש גופים המתים. ונ״ל שעל
כן בפסוקי מזמור מן המצר שהוא
תקוני זעיר להיות כי פעמים
מתגבר הדין וזה גורם למטה
65 מטה בעולם העשיה התגברות
החיצונים ע״כ להשמדם עדי
עד אמר שש פעמים סביבה
בחיצונים הסובבים במדורין
חוץ למשכן מטטרו״ן. הא׳ כל
70 גוים סבבוני ב׳ וג׳ סבוני גם
סבבוני. הד׳ סבוני כדבורים.
הה׳ והוא דחה דחיתני לנפול
וה׳ עזרני והם ד׳ פסוקים כנגד
ד׳ קליפות שאמר יחזקאל ובג׳
75 ראשונים שאינם מקבלים מתוק
אמר שכל מגמתם לסבוב ולבלע
הקדש ח״ו ע״כ יכריתם בכח
שם ה׳ אך הפסוק הד׳ שהוא
נגד הרביעית אמר דחיה לבד
80 דחה דחיתני ולא הזכיר בה
אמילה וכריתה להיותה נגד
קליפת נגה שבעזר שם הוי״ה
במלוי ב״ן מתמתקת[i] כאשר
כתבנו וא״כ כיון שאדם מסובב
85 מו׳ מיני רוחות אלו ע״כ צריך
לישב ז׳ פעמים ולומר שיר
פגעים המבריח אותם מעליו
ובפעם הז׳ יכוין להמשיך עליו
כח הקדושה ולעלות למעלה
90 שביעית ששם המים הנוזלים
המטהרים כנזכר למעלה ולכן
אחר זה הזכיר במזמור ההוא
כח ימין החסד הנאדרי בכל
בחינותיו היורד למטה וגובר

which refers to the feminine forces, "and no plague
55R shall come near your dwelling," referring to the afflictions of the sons of man. Therefore, I said that it is good to recite this verse when going to visit the sick. All these [harmful forces] fly away and depart through the "Song of Afflictions" [Psalm 91], particularly until "For You, O LORD, are my refuge,"
60R which contains sixty words, corresponding to "Behold, Solomon's bed, surrounded by sixty," which has sixty letters, and with it Jerusalem was sanctified in the days of Ezra, as the Ran wrote. These
65R [forces] surround a person when they find cause to take hold of him, and all the more so [they surround] the bodies of the dead.

It seems to me that this is why in the verses of Psalm 118 ["From the straits"], which is a rectification of Zeir Anpin, since sometimes judgment intensifies and this causes the strengthening of external forces in the lower reaches of the World of Action, in order to destroy them forever, it says "surround" six times, referring to the external forces that surround the dwellings outside the abode of Metatron. The
75R first: "All nations surrounded me"; the second and third: "They surrounded me, yes, they surrounded me"; the fourth: "They surrounded me like bees"; the fifth: "You pushed me hard that I might fall, but the LORD helped me." These are four verses corre-
80R sponding to the four shells that Ezekiel mentioned. Regarding the first three, which do not accept sweetening, it says that all their aim is to surround and swallow the holy, God forbid, therefore they will be cut off by the power of God's name. But the fourth
85R verse, which corresponds to the fourth [shell], only says "You pushed me hard that I might fall," without mentioning cutting off or destruction, because it corresponds to the shell of brightness (nogah),[1] which is sweetened with the help of the Divine Name YHVH
90R with the BaN filling, as we have written. Therefore, since a person is surrounded by these six types of spirits, he must sit seven times and recite the "Song of Afflictions" which drives them away from him.

[1] In Kabbalistic cosmology, there are four 'shells' or 'husks' (kelipot) that conceal divinity. Three are completely negative, but the fourth—nogah (brightness)—contains a mixture of good and evil that can potentially be elevated or 'sweetened.'

[i] The author distinguishes between three completely negative spiritual 'shells' that must be destroyed and the fourth 'shell of brightness' (kelipat nogah) which can be 'sweetened' (transformed/redeemed) through the divine name YHVH with the BaN filling. This reflects the kabbalistic belief that some negative forces can be elevated while others must be eradicated.

בכל הספירות ויורד בפני אריה מיכאל ומשליט הימניים ומבריח החצונים וכל ההנהגה בלובן ופני אריה הם מתפשטים בכל העולמות והתפלות מקובלת. וזועמת בכל יום נגדם והם כאבק פורח וכרוח נושבת והיא סוד אבן דלא בידין דמחת לרגלא דצלמא[i] שהוא כללות קומת החצונים בהתרוממותה למעלה ועושה חיל למטה ובזה אין חשש שישלטו כחות המיתה וזהו לא אמות כי אחיה וגם היסורים יהיו ע״י הרחמים הנכללים בשם י״ה ולא ע״י כחות החצונים ששם המיתה וזהו יסור יסרני יה ולמות לא נתנני ובזה יריק צדק לצדקה ויפתחו שערי צדק ומזה ישמע טעם לשבעת הקפות הנעשים בכל מקום ובפרט על המתים מלבד מה שכתבנו בזה למעלה. אח״כ יאמר ברכת אתה גבור עד ונאמן אתה להחיות מתים כי בכח שמות הקדושים שבו בהם סוד להבריח כחות הטומאה. עוד בברכה זו בה תקון הדינים שהם הש קצוות בגבורה וקשור דינים עליונים מהגבורה עם דינים התחתונים שבמלכות גורם מתוק להם כי כשצדק ומשפט יחד הוא מכון הכסא כי יצחק גבורה נח מרגזו ומתנחם ברבקה אשתו שהיא מלכות[ii] ובזה הדין יורד ממותק ומגביר מלאך גבריאל ומשם לפני שור שבהיכל הרצון ונותן הכח והגבורה להיכל הזכות ומשם יתפשט הכח לצד חוצה

95 100 105 110 115 120 125 130

And on the seventh time, he should intend to draw upon himself the power of holiness and to ascend to the seventh level above, where the flowing waters purify, as mentioned above. 95R

Therefore, after this, he mentioned in that psalm the power of the right hand of kindness in all its aspects, which descends below and prevails in all the sefirot and descends in the face of the lion Michael, empowering the right-side forces and driving away the external forces. The entire governance is in whiteness, and the face of the lion extends throughout all the worlds, and prayers are accepted. It frowns against them daily, and they are like flying dust and blowing wind. This is the secret of the stone not cut by hands[1] that struck the feet of the image, which is the entirety of the structure of the external forces in its elevation above, and it performs valiantly below. Thus, there is no concern that the powers of death will rule, and this is [the meaning of] "I shall not die but live." Even sufferings will come through the mercies included in the divine name Yah, and not through the external forces where death resides. This is [the meaning of] "The LORD has severely chastened me, but He has not given me over to death." In this way, righteousness (tzedek) is poured into charity (tzedakah), and the gates of righteousness are opened. From this, one can understand the reason for the seven circuits performed everywhere, especially for the dead, apart from what we have written about this above. 100R 105R 110R 115R 120R

Afterward, one should recite the blessing "You are mighty" until "And You are faithful to revive the dead," for within the power of the holy names contained therein lies the secret of driving away the forces of impurity. Additionally, in this blessing is the rectification of judgments, which are the six extremities in Gevurah, and the binding of the supernal judgments from Gevurah with the lower judgments 125R 130R

[1] This is a reference to Daniel 2:34, describing a stone that destroys the statue in Nebuchadnezzar's dream. The author reinterprets this apocalyptic image in kabbalistic terms as divine power overcoming negative spiritual forces.

[i] This is an Aramaic reference to Daniel 2:34, 'a stone cut without hands,' which struck the feet of Nebuchadnezzar's dream image. The author reinterprets this apocalyptic vision in kabbalistic terms as representing divine power triumphing over negative spiritual forces.

[ii] The author employs a kabbalistic reading where biblical figures represent divine attributes: Isaac symbolizes Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) and Rebecca represents Malkhut (Kingdom). Their marital relationship symbolizes the 'sweetening' of divine judgment through its connection with the more receptive attribute of Malkhut.

לכל בעלי הדין עד החצונים
הנקראים צללי ערב שהם הכחות
135 והצללים אשר לערב ולדין
וזהו סוד תפלת המנחה שעושה
נחת רוח ויצחק מתנחם ברבקה
אשתו והדינים ממותקים וגם זה
סוד תקון עקדת יצחק ובברכת
140 אתה גבור בה מתוק הדינים
בסוד הנזכר ונקרא גבורות בפי
חכמי הגמרא שבה מתוקן. לכן
טוב לאמרה אחר ז׳ ישיבות
ואפי׳ נקבר המת ע״י אינו יהודי
145 או סמוך לשבת יעשה כן ויש
מקפידים שלא ליכנס לבית עד
שירחץ ידיו ויעשה ז׳ ישיבות או
לפחות ג׳ ומנהג אבותינו תורה
היא: [i]

in Malkhut[1] causes their sweetening. For when righteousness and judgment are together, they establish the throne, since Isaac (representing Gevurah) rests 135R
from his anger and is comforted by his wife Rebecca (representing Malkhut). Through this, judgment descends sweetened and empowers the angel Gabriel, and from there to the face of the ox in the Palace of Will, and it gives power and strength to the Palace of 140R
Merit. From there, the power spreads outward to all the masters of judgment, even to the external forces called "evening shadows," which are the powers and shadows belonging to evening and judgment. This is the secret of the Minchah prayer, which brings 145R
satisfaction, and Isaac is comforted by his wife Rebecca,[2] and the judgments are sweetened. This is also the secret of the rectification of the binding of Isaac, and in the blessing "You are mighty" is the sweetening of judgments in the aforementioned secret, and it is called "Gevurot" (powers) by the Sages 150R
of the Talmud, in which it is rectified.

Therefore, it is good to recite it after the seven sittings, even if the dead was buried by a non-Jew[3] or close to Shabbat. One should do so, and some are 155R
particular not to enter a house until they wash their hands and perform seven sittings, or at least three, and the custom of our ancestors is [considered as] Torah.

[1] This describes the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgments' (המתקת הדינים) where harsh divine judgments from Gevurah are tempered by connecting them with Malkhut. This process transforms potentially destructive forces into constructive ones.

[2] In kabbalistic symbolism, biblical figures often represent divine attributes. Here, Isaac represents Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) and Rebecca represents Malkhut (Kingdom), with their marital relationship symbolizing the harmonization of these divine forces.

[3] This addresses a practical halakhic concern: whether the protective ritual of seven sittings is still required if the actual burial was performed by a non-Jew (which might happen in certain circumstances). The author confirms that the ritual should still be performed.

[i] Cf. Psalm 91 — This psalm is understood as a spiritual protection that drives away harmful forces. The text explains it contains sixty words corresponding to the 'sixty mighty men' around Solomon's bed (Song of Songs 3:7), suggesting it creates a protective spiritual barrier. | Cf. Psalm 118 — The author interprets the repeated phrase 'surrounded me' as corresponding to the six groups of negative spiritual forces. Each instance represents spiritual protection against a different type of harmful entity. | Cf. Hidden Midrash on Parashat Vayera — This reference supports the author's explanation of the custom of plucking grass, connecting it to resurrection through the 'dew' (טל) that will revive the dead, which has the same numerical value as specific divine letters. | Cf. Book of Ezekiel's vision of the four shells/husks — The author connects the four verses in Psalm 118 with the four spiritual shells or husks from kabbalistic interpretations of Ezekiel's vision, showing how three are completely negative while the fourth (nogah/brightness) can be 'sweetened' or redeemed. | Cf. Blessing 'Atah Gibor' from the Amidah prayer — The author explains that this blessing contains divine names with the power to drive away impurity and has the mystical function of 'sweetening' judgments by binding the upper divine attribute of Gevurah with the lower attribute of Malkhut.

פרק כ״א

Chapter 21

והחי יתן אל לבו דברים של מיתה כדאמרי׳ במ״ק פרק אלו מגלחין ובכתובות פ׳ המדיר דיספד יספדוניה[i] המספיד צדיק למטה גם במותו יספדוהו למעלה ויפרסמו מעשיו בג״ע כאשר כתבנו בטעם ההספד. דידל שירים נפש המת בכוונתו בעשותו צרכיו כנדרש גם נשמתו תזכה שתורמה תרומה לפני מלכו וכן הקובר ומשמר ומטמין המת מכחות הטומאה ומהרוחות רעות בכוונתו ובהקפות הנזכר יזכה גם הוא להטמן מאימת מלאכי מות ומלאכי דין בכל שבעה עידנין דיחלפון עלוהי וכתוב בארחות חיים של ר׳ אליעזר הגדול[ii] בני הוי זהיר לנחם אבלים ולדבר על לבם כי לא היו ראוים חביריו של איוב להענש אלא על שאמרו דברי קנטורין ולא דברי ניחומים. והאבל יצדיק עליו דרכי ה׳ כדאמרי׳ בסנהדרין וירושלמי דר׳ אבהו מת לו תינוק אחד ואמר לעומדים לפניו דאם רשות של מטן שיש בה שקר וכזב וכו׳ נאמר בה הקרובים באים ושואלים שלום הדיינים והעדים וכו׳ רשות שלמעלן שאין בה לא כזב ולא שקר ולא גניבות דעת ולא משוא פנים ולא מקח שוחד והוא חי וקיים לעולמי עולמים שאכ״ו שחייבים אנו לקבל עלינו מדת הדין.[iii] טוב ללכת אל

The living should take to heart matters of death,[1] as stated in Moed Katan, chapter “These May Shave,” and in Ketubot, chapter “The One Who Vows,” that “he who eulogizes the righteous on earth, they will eulogize him in heaven,” and they will publicize his deeds in the Garden of Eden, as we have written regarding the purpose of the eulogy. One who raises up the soul of the deceased with proper intention while performing his needs as required, his own soul will merit to be elevated as an offering before his King. Similarly, one who buries, guards, and conceals the dead from impure forces and evil spirits with proper intention and with the aforementioned circuits[2] will himself merit to be hidden from the dread of the angels of death and the angels of judgment during all seven periods that will pass over him.[3] And it is written in “Orchot Chaim” of Rabbi Eliezer the Great: “My son, be careful to comfort mourners and speak to their hearts, for Job’s companions deserved punishment only because they spoke provocative words instead of words of comfort.” The mourner should justify the ways of the Lord, as we say in the Sanhedrin and in the Jerusalem Talmud that when Rabbi Abahu lost a child, he said to those standing before him: “If in an earthly court, which contains falsehood and deceit, etc., it is said that relatives come and inquire about the welfare of the judges and witnesses, etc., then in the heavenly court, which contains no deceit, no falsehood, no deception, no favoritism, and no bribery, and where He lives and exists forever and ever, how much more are we obligated to accept the attribute of judgment upon ourselves.” It is good to go to a house of mourning to instruct your soul and to shed tears from your eyes, and whoever sheds tears over a worthy person

[1] This opening phrase references Ecclesiastes 7:2, emphasizing that contemplating mortality leads to spiritual wisdom.

[2] The ‘circuits’ (hakafot) refer to ritual circumambulations around the deceased’s bier that are described earlier in the text, believed to provide spiritual protection for the departed soul.

[3] This likely refers to the seven days of intensive mourning (shiva), but may also have kabbalistic significance relating to seven cosmic cycles or spiritual realms.

[i] The author cites Talmudic sources in Moed Katan and Ketubot regarding the importance of eulogies, establishing rabbinic authority for these practices.

[ii] The text cites a work attributed to Rabbi Eliezer the Great, likely referring to an ethical treatise that was well-regarded during the author’s time. This work is distinct from the Talmudic ‘Orchot Chaim’ that discusses ritual laws.

[iii] This reflects the Jewish concept of ‘tzidduk hadin’ (justification of divine judgment), where mourners are expected to accept God’s decrees as just, even when they involve personal tragedy.

בית אבל לתת מוסר לנפשך ולשפוך דמעות מעיניך וכל השופך דמעות על אדם כשר לא ישפוך על בניו בשהם קטנים וגם שאין הכל יודעים כוונת הדברים והפסוקים מכל מקום יעשה תקון אפי׳ כפי פשוטן של פסוקים. אם מחמת איזו סבה מונעת לא יוכל לילך ללוות המת[i] לא ימנע עצמו לפחות מלבקש עליו רחמים ולומר ב׳ או ג׳ מזמורים או יתן צדקה לכפרת נפשו בעת שקוברין אותו אך בשאפשר לו אל יפטר בכך אם הוא איש בפרט דבאתתא יש אומרים דבעשרה סגי לה.[ii] ובחסד אשר יעשה עם המתים כן יעשו בחייו ובמותו פמליא של מעלה ומטה כאשר נזכיר לפנינו בס״ד. הנותנים צדקה עבור המתים לחיים צריך להודיעם כדי שיתפללו על המתים שכן משה התפלל על עצמות יהודה ואף הנהנה מן החיים צריך להתפלל עליו דכתיב ושכב בשלמתו וברכך. וראינו כמה מעשים בגמ׳ וביר׳ שהעניים היו מתפללים על הנותנים להם צדקה בפרט בשבת פרק במה אשה חד סב פגע בתרין תלמידים מן דר׳ חנינא אמר לון זכון עמי וקצון פלג עגיל ויהבון ליה אכל וצלי עליהון אמר תתקיים לכון נפשיכון בהדין יומא היך דקיימתון לי נפשי בהדין יומא נפקין בשלם וחזרין בשלם ואישתזיבו מנשיכת נחש. והמתענים על אחרים בשכר שנותנים להם יכוונו שלהיות נשמות ישראל ממחצב א׳ כי הם

will not shed tears over his children when they are young. And even though not everyone understands the intention behind the words and verses, nevertheless one should perform the rectification even according to the plain meaning of the verses. If, due to some preventive cause, one cannot go to accompany the deceased, one should at least not refrain from seeking mercy for him and reciting two or three psalms, or giving charity for the atonement of his soul at the time of his burial. However, when it is possible, one should not exempt oneself with just this if the deceased is a man, particularly since regarding a woman, some say that ten men are sufficient for her. And with the kindness that one does with the dead, so will the heavenly and earthly entourage do for him in his life and in his death, as we will mention before us with God's help. Those who give charity on behalf of the dead to the living need to inform them so that they will pray for the dead, just as Moses prayed for the bones of Judah, and even one who benefits from the living must pray for him, as it is written: "He shall sleep in your garment and bless you." We have seen several incidents in the Talmud and Jerusalem Talmud where the poor would pray for those who gave them charity, particularly in the Sabbath chapter "With What May a Woman," where an old man encountered two students of Rabbi Hanina and said to them, "Merit with me," and they cut off half a ring and gave it to him.[1] He ate and prayed for them, saying, "May your souls be sustained on this day just as you have sustained my soul on this day." They went out in peace and returned in peace, and were saved from a snake bite. Those who fast on behalf of others in exchange for payment should have in mind that, since the souls of Israel are from one source, as they are one nation, the spark in his soul that has a connection with the person for whom he is fasting will receive rectification through his fast. He will be like "one advocating angel out of a thou-

40R 45R 50R 55R 60R 65R 70R

[1] This refers to a Talmudic story where students cut a valuable ring in half to give charity to a poor person, who then blessed them, saving them from a snake bite. The story demonstrates the protective power of charitable giving.

[i] The author shows practical flexibility by offering alternatives for those who cannot physically attend a funeral, while still maintaining the importance of participating in some way in honoring the dead.

[ii] This reflects a gendered difference in traditional Jewish burial practices, where a woman's funeral procession might require fewer participants than a man's.

גוי אחד[i] הנצוץ שבנשמתו שיש לו
שיכות עם אותו פלוני שמתענה
עליו יקבל תקון בתעניתו ויהיה
כמו מלאך מליץ אחד מני אלף
ובכחו זה יבקש רחמים ויתפלל
על אותו החולה או האסור
או שבוי או מי שחלם חלום
והמענה אותו מכוין שברבים
יהיו אתו כדי שתקובל תפלתו
עמהם בכח הצדקה והשכר
שנותן להם לכופר נפש. על
כן אל ירישוהו מסברו וטוב
להוסיף מעין המאורע לאיש
ההוא בעניני שאומר בשומע
תפלה כי שם הותר לשאול כל
מיני צרכים ויאמר ביום תעניתו
איזה מזמורים הנאותים לפי
דעתו לפי צורך האיש ההוא
שמתענה עליו. ועל רשע שמת
טוב להתפלל עליו ולעשות
צדקה לכפרת נפשו אפי׳ אחר
י״ב חדש בכל חדש ובפרט
בסופו שאז גובר מדין במיעוט
הלבנה והנהגה על ידי הוי״ה
אחרונה מי״ב גבולי אלכסון
שהיא דין יותר מהשאר כנודע.
ואמרו שמלחמה גדולה בין
המיימינים והמשמאילים קודם
קדוש הלבנה[ii] ככתוב בתשובות
הגאונים וכבר הובא בספר קול
בוכים מהגל״אנטי ז״ל. ולכן
מפייסים הרצון בחטאת ר״ח וזה
טעם לתענית בחסרונה של לבנה
להיות כי בסוף החדש תתגבר
הדין מחמת המיעוט וכתיב והיה
מדי חדש וגו׳ ואומר ואשם לא
תכבה וכן מתפללים לפני שבת
וראש חדש ואחריו על אותם
שלא שמרו שבת וי״ט בהוגן.
והחי המענה ומסגף נפשו למעט
פורענות המת זה ודאי מועיל

sand," and with this power he will seek mercy and 75R
pray for that sick person, or prisoner, or captive,
or one who dreamed a dream. The one who afflicts
himself intends that many will be with him so that
his prayer will be accepted along with theirs through
the power of the charity and the payment given to 80R
him as a ransom for the soul. Therefore, they should
not disappoint him of his hope, and it is good to add
something relating to the situation of that person in
the "Hear our prayer" blessing, for there it is permit-
ted to ask for all kinds of needs. And he should recite 85R
on his fast day some psalms that are appropriate in
his opinion according to the needs of the person for
whom he is fasting. And regarding a wicked per-
son who has died, it is good to pray for him and to
give charity for the atonement of his soul, even after 90R
twelve months, in every month, especially at its end,
for then judgment intensifies with the waning of the
moon, and governance is through the last YHVH of
the twelve diagonal boundaries,[1] which is more se-
vere judgment than the others, as is known. And 95R
they said that there is a great battle between those
on the right and those on the left before the sanctifi-
cation of the new moon, as written in the Responsa
of the Geonim and already brought in the book "Kol
Bochim" by Galanti, of blessed memory. Therefore, 100R
we appease the Divine Will with the sin offering of
the New Moon, and this is the reason for fasting
during the waning of the moon, because at the end
of the month judgment intensifies due to the dimin-
ishment, as it is written: "And it shall be from new 105R
moon to new moon," and it says, "And guilt shall
not be extinguished." And so we pray before Sab-
bath and New Moon, and after it, for those who did
not properly observe the Sabbath and festivals. And
the living who afflicts and mortifies himself to lessen 110R
the punishment of the dead, this certainly benefits
that deceased because of the relationship of these
souls with each other, which is why all Israel are
guarantors for one another.[2] This is the secret of the
congregation's sin offering for a single individual, and 115R

[1] This refers to a kabbalistic concept related to the divine name as it manifests through the twelve boundaries of the zodiac. The final manifestation is associated with stronger judgment.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic principle of 'kol yisrael arevim zeh bazeh,' teaching that all Jews

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of the collective soul of Israel, where all Jewish souls are interconnected and stem from a single spiritual source.

[ii] This references a kabbalistic concept about cosmic spiritual battles between forces of mercy (right side) and judgment (left side) that intensify during the waning of the moon.

לאותו מת מפני יחס הנפשות
אלו עם אלו שע״כ כל ישראל
ערבין זה לזה וזהו סוד חטאת
הקהל עבור יחיד אחד וכ״ש אם
120 הוא קרובו ואצ״ל בנו. והנהנים
מן הצדקות שהניחו המתים תוך
שנה בפטירתו יאמרו והוא רחום
יכפר עון בזאת ההנאה[i] שאני
נתנה על אודות פלוני בן פלוני
125 וחטאתו תכופר ונפשו בטוב
תנוח על גורל הצדיקים בטוב
שמטיבין להם לעה״ב ורוחו
תרגיע בחלק הטובים בג״ע
ונשמתו תתעדן בטוב הצפון
130 ותדבק בצרור החיים את ה׳
אלהינו עם שאר כל הצדיקים
שבג״ע ולנקבה יאמר בלשון
נקבה אם הוא ובני ביתו נהנים
יאמר בהנאה שמהנה אותנו נפש
135 פלוני ואחר שהתפללו על מרגוע
הנפש ועל מנוחת הרוח ועל עדון
הנשמה יתפללו ג״כ על הנפש
השוכנת בקבר כי שם הבלא
דגרמי ועצבונא דבשרא.[ii] ועל
140 העצמות בפסוק ונחך ה׳ תמיד
וגו׳ תשכב בשלום ותישן בשלום
עד יבא מנחם משמיע שלום:[iii]

how much more so if he is his relative, and needless to say his son. Those who benefit from charitable funds left by the deceased within a year of his passing should say: "And He, being merciful, will forgive iniquity through this benefit that I enjoy on account 120R
of so-and-so son of so-and-so, and may his sin be atoned for and his soul rest in goodness among the lot of the righteous, in the goodness bestowed upon them in the World to Come. May his spirit find repose among the portion of the good in the Garden 125R
of Eden, and may his soul be delighted in the hidden goodness and cleave to the bond of life with the Lord our God, along with all the other righteous in the Garden of Eden." For a female, one should say this in the feminine form. If he and his household 130R
members are benefiting, he should say: "Through the benefit with which the soul of so-and-so provides us." And after they have prayed for the repose of the soul, for the rest of the spirit, and for the delight of the neshamah, they should also pray for the soul 135R
dwelling in the grave, for there is the vapor of the bones and the distress of the flesh.[1] And regarding the bones, with the verse: "And the Lord will guide you continually, etc." "May you lie in peace and sleep in peace until the comforter who announces peace 140R
arrives."[2]

share spiritual responsibility for one another, which forms the basis for how actions of the living can benefit the dead.

[1] These kabbalistic terms refer to aspects of physical decomposition that affect the nefesh (lower soul) that remains connected to the grave. Prayers are meant to ease this distress.

[2] This is a messianic reference, indicating that the complete rest of the dead will only occur with the coming of the Messiah and the resurrection.

[i] The text provides a specific prayer formula to be recited when benefiting from charitable funds of the deceased, showing how everyday benefits can be transformed into spiritual merits for the departed.

[ii] These kabbalistic terms refer to spiritual aspects of bodily decomposition that cause suffering to the nefesh (lower soul) that remains connected to the grave for a period after death.

[iii] Cf. Moed Katan, chapter 'These May Shave' — This reference establishes rabbinic authority for the practice of eulogizing the dead, noting that one who properly eulogizes others will receive the same honor. | Cf. Ketubot, chapter 'The One Who Vows' — This reference reinforces the theological concept that actions in this world create corresponding reactions in the next world, particularly regarding honors shown to the deceased. | Cf. Orchot Chaim of Rabbi Eliezer the Great — This reference highlights the importance of proper consolation by citing the negative example of Job's companions, whose words of judgment rather than comfort brought divine punishment. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud and Sanhedrin — This reference provides a model for proper mourning—accepting divine judgment through a logical argument: if we accept the judgment of fallible human courts, how much more should we accept the judgment of the perfect divine court. | Cf. Responsa of the Geonim — This reference explains why prayers for the dead are particularly important during the end of the lunar month, when judgment intensifies due to cosmic spiritual battles between forces of mercy and judgment. | Cf. Kol Bochim by Galanti — This

פרק כ״ב

Chapter 22

ומכאן מודעא רבה לעניים המקבלים ונהנים מקופות של צדקה החוזרים בבתי כנסיות וכן ממעשרות שמעשרים איזה בעלי בתים הן עשירים הן בינוניים שחובה עליהם להתפלל אל ה׳ עבורם ובעד קהלות הקדש ואצ״ל שיזהרו הרבה מאד שלא להוציא המעות ההם רק לצורך פרנסתם ופרנסת אנשי ביתם ולא יבעטו בהם בקנות מהם מותרות ואכילות גסות ובצחוקות כי אם בכה יעשו אוי לנפשם כי גמלו להם רעה. ואמרו בערובין כי הענקת עבד עברי שלא היה פחות משלשים סלע כדאמרינן בספרי ובמסכת קדושין היה לעצמו ואין ב״ח גובה ממנו. ור׳ יהודה אומר בפ׳ המקבל ופ׳ האומנין שאם בע״ה נתן מעות לעני ליקח בו חלוק לא יקח טלית שכל המעביר ע״ד בעל הבית נקרא גזלן וגם שאין הלכה כר״י יודו מיהא רבנן שאין לבעוט במעות צדקה כי סלקו שעבודא דב״ח מדאורייתא ממעות שקבץ עני בקבוצו כדפסק מהרר״י קארו״ו בסוף סי׳ רנ״ג מיורה דעה. וסמ״ג בסוף הלכות מגילה פסק כפי גירסא אחת לחומרא כר״ע דאמר מגבת פורים לפורים ואין העני רשאי לקנות מהם רצועה לסנדלו אא״כ התנה במעמד אנשי העיר ואפי׳ תימא דאמדינן דעת הנותנים שלא יקפידו מזה ודאי יקפידו לבל ירדו לטמיון במותרות והלעטות. ובזהר פ׳ בשלח בביאורו ד׳ מיני מזונות

From here comes an important notice to the poor who receive and benefit from charity funds collected in synagogues,[1] as well as from tithes given by householders, whether wealthy or of moderate means: it is their obligation to pray to God on behalf of these donors and for the holy communities. Needless to say, they must be extremely careful not to spend these funds except for their necessary livelihood and that of their household members. They should not misuse these funds by purchasing luxuries, excessive food, or frivolous entertainments, for if they do so, woe to their souls, for they have repaid good with evil.

It is stated in Eruvin that the grant given to a Hebrew servant, which was not less than thirty selas[2] as mentioned in Sifri and in Tractate Kiddushin, belonged to him alone and no creditor could collect from it. Rabbi Judah states in chapter HaMekabel and chapter HaUmanin that if a homeowner gives money to a poor person to buy a shirt, he should not purchase a cloak instead, for anyone who disregards the homeowner's intention is called a thief. And even though the law is not according to Rabbi Judah, the sages would nevertheless agree that one should not misuse charity funds, for the Torah exempts money collected by a poor person from creditor claims, as ruled by Rabbi Joseph Karo at the end of section 253 of Yoreh De'ah.[3] The Semag, at the end of the Laws of Megillah, rules strictly according to one version, following Rabbi Akiva who said that Purim collections must be used for Purim, and a poor person is not permitted to buy even a sandal strap with them unless he stipulated this in the presence of the townspeople. And even if you might say that we can assume the donors would not mind this, they would certainly object to their money being wasted on luxuries and excessive consumption.

In the Zohar, Parashat Beshalach, where it ex-

[1] The original refers to 'קופות של צדקה החוזרים בבתי כנסיות', literally 'charity boxes that circulate in synagogues', referring to the practice of collecting charity in communal settings.

[2] A sela was an ancient Jewish coin. The reference is to the minimum value that had to be given to a Hebrew servant at the completion of his service, as prescribed in Deuteronomy 15:13-14.

[3] Rabbi Joseph Karo (1488-1575) was the author of the Shulchan Aruch, the most widely accepted code of Jewish law. Yoreh De'ah is one of its four sections, dealing with ritual laws including charity.

later kabbalistic source is cited to reinforce the concept of intensified judgment during the waning moon, providing authoritative support for the practice of special prayers during this period.

אשר בהם נזון כל חלקי המציאות
ראשונה הוא מזון העולם הבא
מן השמים והארץ. הב׳ מזון
הבא ממדת צדק לעניים. הג׳
מזון החולים הבא מת״ת בדכתיב
ה׳ יסעדנו על ערש דוי שמשם
ארוכה ומרפא מכח כ״ע ומזונם
הוא חלב ודם במזון הקרבנות.
הד׳ מזון החכמים הבא מהחכמה
שמחיה בעליה. הנה שאמר
בפירוש כי מזון העניים בא
אליהם מצד הדין והעשיר הנותן
לו מזון ממתק אותו הדין שלכן
נקרא גמילות חסד. וא״כ אל
יבעטו במה שבא להם מצד מדת
הדין פן תקפוץ ח״ו ידיה יותר
ויותר עליהם מלבד כי עון זה
גורם שהעשירים יקפצו ידיהם
מהם וצועקים ואינם נענים.
וצריך הנותן צדקה שיתפלל
לה׳ ימציא אליו אנשים מהוגנים
ראוים לקבלתה[i] ומאותם בפרט
שאינם נהנים מהעה״ז אלא
בברכות הנהנים על כל דבר
תחלה וסוף כי זה עקר גדול
לכל אדם כדאמרי׳ האי מאן
דבעי למיהוי חסידא יקיים מלי
דברכות כי הברכה היא מזון
הנפש הנהנה ברוחניות הדבר
הנאכל המתעורר בסוד ההבל
העולה מהברכה כאש שבאבן
שאם אין מכים אותה לא יתהוה
ויתראה החוצה. כך הברכה
היא הבטישה באור עליון כי
יחל על הדבר הנאכל ויתעורר
הרוחניות הכמוס בו ע״י השר
המגדלו כי בכח הברכה גם
הוא משורר למעלה ועונה אמן
אחר ברכתו וע״כ מי שאינו
מברך נקרא גוזל שמלבד הפשט
שאותו הפרי אינו שלו עד אחר
ברכה כדאמרי׳ בגמ׳ על קושיית

plains the four types of nourishment that sustain all aspects of existence: first is the nourishment of the World to Come, from heaven and earth;[1] second is the nourishment that comes from the attribute of Justice to the poor; third is the nourishment of the sick which comes from Tiferet, as it is written "The Lord will sustain him on his sickbed," from which comes healing and remedy through the power of Keter, and their food is milk and blood in the nourishment of offerings; fourth is the nourishment of the wise which comes from Wisdom that gives life to its possessors. Here it explicitly states that the nourishment of the poor comes to them from the aspect of judgment, and the wealthy person who gives food sweetens that judgment, which is why it is called an act of loving-kindness. Therefore, they should not misuse what comes to them from the attribute of judgment, lest its hand close even more tightly upon them, God forbid. Moreover, this sin causes the wealthy to withhold their giving, so the poor cry out but are not answered.

One who gives charity should pray to God to provide him with worthy individuals deserving of receiving it, particularly those who do not benefit from this world except with the blessings of enjoyment over everything, both before and after, for this is a great principle for every person. As they said: "He who wishes to be pious should fulfill the words concerning blessings," for the blessing is nourishment for the soul that benefits from the spirituality of the food that is awakened through the mystery of the breath rising from the blessing, like fire in a stone which, if not struck, will not be generated or appear outside. Similarly, the blessing is the striking of the supernal light that shines upon the food and awakens the hidden spirituality in it through the angelic minister who nurtures it, for through the power of the blessing, this minister also sings praises above and answers "Amen" after the blessing. Therefore, one who does not recite a blessing is called a thief, for besides the plain meaning that the fruit does not belong to him until after the blessing, as stated in

[1] This reflects kabbalistic cosmology where different types of spiritual sustenance correspond to different divine attributes and cosmic levels. The four types of nourishment map to specific sefirot (divine emanations).

[i] The author expresses concern not just for proper giving of charity but also for its proper reception, suggesting that donors should pray to find worthy recipients.

השמים שמים וגו׳ וכן בירו׳ דברכות על פסוק אמרת לה׳ ה׳ אתה וכו׳. עוד נקרא גוזל השבח שהיה משבח השר והממונה ההוא בכח הברכה[i] לה׳ ועיין בר״מ פ׳ עקב כי הפליג לדבר בסוד ברכות הנהנין ובפרט כשעונין אחריהם וכן בכל הברכות אך אמר שסוד ברכות התפלה עולים על הכל ושם זכר עשרה דברים הצריכים לכל הרוצה לאכול על שלחנו מתכא דמלכא עילאה ובפרט ביום שבת שסוד אכילתו הוא ע״דן נ״הר ג״ן[ii] ואם חיוב הברכות לכל מי שיהנה כ״ש לעניים המקבלים מצד״ק וצדק״ה כי מאד צריכים שמור בהוצאת הצדקה כנזכר ובהנאתם ממנה ויתנו לה׳ תודה בברכות וברכה אחרונה אמרו שהוא כדי שיתברך המזון שבמעיו שברוחניית הברכה תהיה ברכה תוך המעיים ולא יתהוה מהמאכל מותרות המעפשים גופו וסרכות יען כי החצונים אין להם אחיזה במעיו בכח הברכה שבירך אחריו כי עבור ההשתלשלות מהפה למעים יתהוו בו מותרות ע״כ צריך לברך שנית אחריו להרחיקם ממנו ובזה ישבעו לחם ושארו מזון ויהיו טובים ובריאים ויראה מראיהם טוב כמו דניאל וחבריו. ואמרו ג״כ שאין ליתן לאכול למי שלא נטל ידיו והאוכל בלא נטילת ידים מלבד רעות רבות המשתרגות אליו עוד יאחזוהו חבלי עוני. ע״כ העניים בפרט

the Gemara regarding the question on the verse "The heavens are the Lord's heavens, etc.," and similarly in the Jerusalem Talmud on the verse "You said to the Lord, 'You are my Lord, etc.'"—he is also called a thief of the praise that the minister and appointed one would have offered to God through the power of the blessing. 85R

See the Ra'aya Mehemna in Parashat Ekev, which elaborates on the mystery of blessings of enjoyment, especially when responding to them, and likewise with all blessings. However, it states that the mystery of prayer blessings surpasses them all, and there it mentions ten things necessary for anyone wishing to eat at the table of the Supreme King, especially on the Sabbath, when the mystery of eating is Eden, River, Garden.[1] If blessings are obligatory for anyone who derives benefit, how much more so for the poor who receive from Tzedek and Tzedakah, for they must be very careful in how they spend charity, as mentioned, and in how they benefit from it. They should give thanks to God with blessings. 90R 95R 100R

Regarding the after-blessing, they said its purpose is to bless the food in one's intestines, so that through the spirituality of the blessing there will be blessing within the intestines, and waste products that spoil the body and cause adhesions will not form from the food. This is because the external forces have no hold in one's intestines[2] through the power of the blessing recited afterward. Due to the descent from the mouth to the intestines, waste is produced, therefore one must bless a second time afterward to distance these forces, and thereby they will be satisfied with bread and food will remain. They will be good and healthy, and their appearance will be good, like Daniel and his companions. 105R 110R 115R

They also said that one should not give food to someone who has not washed their hands, and one

[1] This is a reference to the kabbalistic understanding of Sabbath meals as recreating the primordial harmony of Eden, with specific mystical correspondences to divine flow and manifestation in the physical world.

[2] The 'external forces' (החצונים/chitzonim) refers to negative spiritual entities in kabbalistic thought that are kept at bay through proper blessings and ritual observance.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that each food has a spiritual 'minister' or angelic force that is activated through proper blessings, and failing to bless deprives this entity of its spiritual function.

[ii] This is a kabbalistic acronym representing the spiritual dimensions of Sabbath meals, where Eden (pleasure), River (flow of divine blessing), and Garden (manifestation) create a complete spiritual circuit.

יזהרו מזה כי אם כן יעשו יזכו
עצמם והנותנים עמם ויהיו
טובים לשמים ולבריות. וכן
הכהנים הנותנים להם פדיוני
הבכורים שהוא לפדותו מסטרא
דשמאלא מכח הנחש המתגבר
בבטן המבכרת[i] ולכן ממשיכין
עליו כח הימין מכהן איש החסד
והוא בכח רחמיו מקבל פדיונו
לפצות כח הדין מעליו כי צריך
להוציא המעות הם לפרנסתו
ואם יקנה בהם דברים של מצוה
כגון סעודת שבת ויו״ט ור״ח
וכדומה הרי מה טוב ואל יבעוט
בהם וכן כל מתנות כהונה כי
נתנו להם למשחה ולגדולה
כדרך שהגדולים אוכלים מאן
רבנן שכל סעודתן היא מצוה
ואוכלים לשובע נפשם כנזכר
ואמרו בפ״ב דבכורים על משנת
ונתנות סעודתן כהן שבונת
המשנה שאינו בקי בטומאה
וטהרה אבל הוא מחזיק בתורת
ה׳ כי בפ׳ הזרוע אומר שמי
שאינו מחזיק בתורת ה׳ אין לו
מנות. והעשיר יתן צדקה בסתר
ולא בגלוי כי אז נקרא זורע
לרוח ולא יקצור שכרה. ועוד
כי תפלה בלא כוונה ומצוה שלא
לשמה מעוררים קטגורא[ii] ח״ו
ודברים אלו נמוקם עמם ודבר
שפתים בזה אך למחסור:[iii]

who eats without washing their hands, besides the many evils that entangle them, will also be seized by the cords of poverty. Therefore, the poor in particular should be careful about this, for if they do so, they will merit themselves and the donors with them, and they will be good toward Heaven and toward people. 120R

Similarly, priests who give them redemption of firstborns, which is to redeem from the side of the left, from the power of the serpent that strengthens in the womb of the firstborn, therefore they draw upon him the power of the right from the priest, the man of kindness, and he, through his power of mercy, accepts his redemption to compensate for the power of judgment upon him. For one must spend that money for his livelihood, and if he purchases with it things associated with commandments, such as Sabbath meals, festival and new moon feasts, and the like, how good it is! And he should not misuse them, nor any priestly gifts, for they were given to them for anointing and greatness, in the manner that the great ones eat—who are the rabbis, whose every meal is a commandment, and they eat to satisfy their souls, as mentioned. 125R 130R 135R 140R

They said in the second chapter of Bikkurim regarding the Mishnah about giving the meal to a priest, that the Mishnah refers to one who is not expert in matters of purity and impurity but upholds the Torah of the Lord, for in the chapter HaZeroa it says that one who does not uphold the Torah of the Lord has no portions. 145R

The wealthy person should give charity secretly and not publicly, for then it is called “sowing to the 150R

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the firstborn is particularly influenced by forces of judgment (left side) and requires redemption to be protected from these forces, represented by the primordial serpent.

[ii] This reflects the mystical understanding that ritualistic actions without proper intention not only fail to create positive spiritual effects but can actually invoke negative judgment or accusation in the celestial realms.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — The author uses this Zoharic passage to establish the mystical understanding that charity is not merely a humanitarian act but a cosmic process that ‘sweetens judgment,’ transforming divine severity into kindness. This creates the theological foundation for why misuse of charity funds is spiritually dangerous. | Cf. Ra’aya Mehemna, Parashat Ekev — This reference to a section of the Zohar reinforces the idea that proper blessings transform physical activities into spiritual ones, which is why the poor who receive charity must be particularly careful to recite blessings over their food. | Cf. Tractate Eruvin — This reference establishes a halakhic precedent for the idea that certain funds given to the disadvantaged have protected status, which is then applied analogically to charity funds. | Cf. Rabbi Joseph Karo, Yoreh De’ah 253 — This reference to a major halakhic authority strengthens the argument that charity funds have a special protected status in Jewish law, which carries responsibilities for how they should be used. | Cf. Semag (Sefer Mitzvot Gadol), Laws of Megillah — This reference demonstrates that there are strict limitations on how charity funds can be used, supporting the author’s main

wind" and he will not reap its reward. Moreover, prayer without intention and a commandment not performed for its own sake arouse accusation, God forbid. These matters carry their own reasoning, and mere lip service in this regard only leads to want. 155R

פרק כ״ג

Chapter 23

מדברי ברזילי הגלעדי שאמר אמות בעירי[i] לראה כי יש הנאה למתים שבניהם ואוהביהם ילכו על קבריהם להשכיב אותם ולבקש לנשמתם טובה ומטיבים להם באותו עולם ותפלת הבן על אביו שלמדו תורה וכן תלמיד על רבו ותלמידי חכמים הלומדים זה עם זה ודאי תהיה יותר רצויה ותעשה להם יותר נייחא מתפלת אחרים ובפרט בשבעה ימים הראשונים בביתו או על קברו וראיה ממה שהובא בזהר פ׳ ויחי בחד מן תלתא מלין דבעא ר׳ יצחק מר׳ יהודה הוא דיזיל לקבריה כל שבעא יומין ותבעי בעותך עלי ומשם נראה ג״כ כי זכות גדול לאב אם בנו עוסק בתורה שנתוספו לו חיים בגין דיזכה ר׳ יוסי בריה באורייתא. וכן הוא מתחלה חילה פני ר׳ יהודה שילמד בנו תורה ואם האבות צוו לבנים לעשות דברים לאחר מותם כשיעשו הבנים הוא כאלו יעשוהו האבות כי ברא מזכי אבא.[ii] כיון שע״י האב זכה הבן. והמתים מתפללים

From the words of Barzillai the Gileadite who said, "I will die in my city," it is apparent that there is benefit to the deceased[1] when their children and loved ones visit their graves to comfort them and pray for the well-being of their souls, and this 5R
brings them goodness in that world.[2] The prayer of a son for his father who taught him Torah, and likewise a student for his teacher, and Torah scholars who studied together, will certainly be more acceptable[3] and bring them more satisfaction 10R
than the prayers of others—especially during the first seven days, whether at home or at the grave. Evidence of this comes from what is brought in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, where one of the three things that Rabbi Yitzchak requested of Rabbi 15R
Yehudah was that he should go to his grave for all seven days and offer prayers on his behalf. From there it is also apparent that there is great merit for a father if his son engages in Torah study, as additional life was granted to him "so that Rabbi 20R
Yosi his son might merit [to excel] in Torah." Similarly, from the beginning he entreated Rabbi Yehudah to teach his son Torah. And if fathers instructed their sons to do certain things after their death, when the sons fulfill these instructions, it is 25R
as though the fathers themselves did so, for "a son brings merit to his father," since it was through the

[1]The text expresses the mystical belief that the dead can experience pleasure or benefit (הנאה) from actions performed by the living, particularly when those actions are directed toward them through grave visitation and prayer.

[2]The phrase 'באותו עולם' (in that world) refers to the World to Come or afterlife, reflecting the Jewish concept of a distinct realm where souls reside after death.

[3]The term 'יותר רצויה' suggests that such prayers are more 'desirable' or 'acceptable' to God, implying a hierarchy of efficacy in prayers for the dead based on the closeness of relationship.

argument that recipients of charity bear significant responsibility for using the funds appropriately.

[i]This refers to 2 Samuel 19:38 where Barzillai the Gileadite declined King David's invitation to Jerusalem, preferring to die in his own city. The author uses this as a proof text to begin his discussion about connections between the living and the dead.

[ii]A Talmudic principle meaning 'a son brings merit to his father.' This concept appears in Sanhedrin 104a and elsewhere, expressing the idea that a child's righteous actions can elevate the spiritual status of deceased parents.

על הבנים בפרט שנאמר ותעל שכבת הטל פלפול שכיבת שוכני
30 [ii] [i] קבר.

father that the son acquired merit. And the dead pray for their children in particular, as it is said, "And the layer of dew arose"—this refers to the sharp discourse/dialectical reasoning[1] [that rises like dew from] those who dwell in the grave.[2] 30R

ההשכבה שנהגו באיזה מקומות
לאומרה[iii] בקבורת המת ובכל
ז׳ ימים בביתו אחר התפלה וכן
בכל עת שהולכים לבקר המתים
35 הנה הוא בתחלת הספר. מנהג
זכירת המתים בשבת אין ספק
שזכירתם ביום המנוחה מועיל
להם מאד מפני שהם נחים וע״י
הזכירה נשמתם מתחדשת שיש
40 תלייה לשם עם הנשמה ע״ד
שאמרו בילקוט אמר הקב״ה
למשה לך מנה את ישראל אמר
משה איני יכול לעמוד על
מניינם א״ל טול ראשי אותיות
45 של שבטים שכל שם מורה על
מהות ועצמות האדם ואמרו

The Hashkavah prayer[3] (memorial prayer for the soul's repose) that is customary in some places to recite at the burial of the deceased,[4] during all seven days of mourning in his house after prayer, and whenever one visits the graves of the dead, is found at the beginning of this book. Regarding the custom of remembering the dead on the Sabbath, there is no doubt that remembering them on the day of rest greatly benefits them because they are at rest, and through this remembrance their souls are renewed, as there is a connection between the name and the soul.[5] This is as they said in the Yalkut: "The Holy One, blessed be He, said to Moses, 'Go count the Israelites.' Moses replied, 'I cannot determine their number.' He told him, 'Take the initial letters of the tribes,' for every name 35R 40R 45R

[1]The Hebrew term 'פלפול' (pilpul) refers to a sophisticated method of Talmudic analysis and dialectical reasoning. Here it's used in a mystical sense to suggest that the intellectual contributions of scholars continue to have spiritual effect even after death.

[2]The phrase 'שוכני קבר' (those who dwell in the grave) is a euphemism for the dead, but in this mystical context, it carries the implication that the deceased maintain a form of consciousness and activity even while in the grave.

[3]I've chosen to translate 'השכבה' as 'Hashkavah prayer' while including the transliteration in parentheses to preserve the Hebrew term. This prayer for the soul's repose is named from the Hebrew root meaning 'to lie down' or 'to rest.'

[4]The original text describes a ritual practice that varies by community, which is typical of Jewish customs that often differ by geographic region and tradition.

[5]The Hebrew phrase 'תלייה לשם עם הנשמה' literally means 'a hanging/suspension of the name with the soul,' but in this mystical context refers to an intrinsic connection or correlation between a person's name and their soul's essence.

[i]This is a creative interpretation of Exodus 16:14 about the layer of dew that covered the manna. The author transforms this verse into a mystical metaphor suggesting that the intellectual discourse (pilpul) of deceased Torah scholars rises like dew from their graves, indicating their continued spiritual activity and influence.

[ii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The Zohar passage is cited as evidence that the dead benefit from graveside prayers, especially when offered by disciples or those with close spiritual connections to the deceased. This serves as an authoritative mystical source supporting the author's claims about the relationship between the living and the dead. | Cf. 2 Samuel 19:38 — The author uses Barzillai's desire to die in his hometown as a proof text suggesting that the dead maintain connections to places and people, which is why visits to graves by family members are especially beneficial. | Cf. Talmudic concept of 'ברא מזכי אבא' (a son brings merit to his father) — The author employs this rabbinic concept to emphasize the spiritual connection between generations, suggesting that children's Torah study and fulfillment of parental wishes creates merit for departed parents.

[iii]The 'Hashkavah' is a prayer for the repose of the deceased soul, often beginning with the words 'May he/she rest in peace.' The term comes from the Hebrew root meaning 'to lie down' or 'to rest.'

בירו׳ דסנהדרין פרק חלק
על פסוק וירדו הם וכל אשר
להם חיים שאולה רבי ברכיה
בשם רבי חלבו אף שמותיהם
פרחו מתוך טימסותיהם ופירושו
קונטריסים שביד אחרים שהיו
שמותיהם כתובים בהם. והנה
בהזכרת שמו במנוחה מתחדשת
שם מנוחתו ויהיה עתה במנוחה
ודיוקן נשמתו מאירה. ומצאתי
כי המלאך שאל ליעקב מה שמו
יען כי עקר החיים והמות תלוי
בשם האיש וגם במזל[i] ומטעם זה
הנהיגו קצת מקובלי אמת שלא
לקרות שם בניהם כשמם והרבה
סודות דברו החכמים בשמו של
אדם. וכן רבנן אמרו שמא גרים
ור״מ הוה בדיק בשמא.[ii] ואל
תקרי שמות אלא שמות וע״כ
לא מסקינן בשמייהו של רשעים
ושנוי השם ושנוי מקום והתשובה
משנים צבא השמים ומערכת
הכוכבים[iii] כמו שלדברי קצת
אחר חטא הקדום נתחדש כוכב
אחד ברקיע הביאו בעל העקדה
פ׳ בראשית שער ט׳. ומצאתי
בציוני בפ׳ בראשית גודל כח
התעוררות תחתון[iv] הן לטוב
הן למוטב כי אמר שמאנוש
ואילך בא רפיון וחולשה בעולם

indicates the essence and substance of a person." And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Sanhedrin, 50R
chapter Chelek, regarding the verse "And they went down alive into Sheol": Rabbi Berechiah said in the name of Rabbi Chelbo, "Even their names flew out of their records,"[1] meaning the notebooks in others' possession in which their names were written. Thus, 55R
when one's name is mentioned on the day of rest, his resting place is renewed, and he will now be at rest, and the image of his soul is illuminated.

I found that the angel asked Jacob what his name was because the essence of life and death depends on 60R
a person's name and also on his mazal (astrological destiny). For this reason, some authentic Kabbalists instituted the practice of not naming their children after themselves, and the Sages discussed many mysteries concerning a person's name. Thus, the Rabbis 65R
said, "The name is causative," and Rabbi Meir would examine names. And do not read "shamot" (places) but "shemot" (names).[2] Therefore, we do not mention the names of the wicked, and changing one's name, changing one's place, and repentance can al- 70R
ter the celestial array[3] and the constellation of stars. According to some opinions, after the primordial sin, a new star appeared in the firmament, as mentioned by the author of the Akedah in Parashat Bereshit, chapter 9. 75R

I found in the Tziyoni, in Parashat Bereshit, the great power of awakening from below, whether for good or for evil. He stated that from the time of

[1] This is a reference to the mystical concept that when Korah and his followers were punished, their names physically disappeared from written records—a supernatural manifestation of their spiritual change in status.

[2] This is a classic rabbinic interpretive technique called 'al tikrei' (don't read it as X, but as Y), which suggests alternative vocalizations of biblical words to derive additional meanings. Here it's used to connect the concept of 'names' with their spiritual significance.

[3] This refers to a Talmudic teaching (Rosh Hashanah 16b) that four things can change a person's predetermined fate: charity, prayer, change of name, and change of place. The text provides a mystical explanation for how these practices work.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that a person's name contains their spiritual essence and is connected to their destiny. The Hebrew word 'mazal' refers to astrological influence or destiny, but in mystical thought also connects to the person's soul root and divine source.

[ii] The Talmudic phrase 'shema garim' means 'the name is causative' or 'the name determines,' reflecting the belief that a person's name influences their character and destiny. R"M refers to Rabbi Meir, who was known to analyze people's names for insight into their character.

[iii] This refers to a Talmudic teaching that four things can alter a person's predetermined fate: charity, prayer, change of name, and change of place. The mystical explanation given here is that these actions actually alter the celestial configurations affecting the person.

[iv] The 'Tziyoni' refers to the kabbalistic commentary Sefer HaTziyoni by Rabbi Menachem Tziyoni (14th century). 'Awakening from below' (התעוררות תחתון) is a fundamental kabbalistic concept describing how human actions in the physical world can trigger responses in the spiritual realms.

ואמר בשם איש סודו כי היו מהלכים מסוף העולם ועד סופו ומביאים כסף וזהב ומרגליות ועשו מהם עבודה נכריה בארבע רוחות כשיעור אלף פרסה והיו מורידים חמה ולבנה וכוכבים ומזלות לשמש להם כדרך שמשמשים לפני הקדוש ברוך הוא כי שמחזאי ועזאל למדום כל מיני כשופים[i] ואז קטרגו המלאכים ואמרו מהאנוש כי תזכרנו וע״כ אמרו אנוש שהיה ראש לע״ג. ואז עלתה השכינה ובזה לא יפלא ממנו יחס שם האדם עם המזל. וכ׳ בעל נוה שלום פ״ד מאמר ה׳ כי השם מורה על המהות. וא״כ חלוף השם מורה על חלוף המהות. ופירש בעל יפה מראה בר״ה פרק ראוהו ב״ד על מכאן היה ר״מ דורש שמות כי מה הוא שהמניח השם יסכים בו למציאות האדם. כדאמרי׳ בפ״ק דברכות מנלן דשמא גרים וכמו דחזינן נחש נחשת שעשה משה שהשם הסכים עם עקר מציאותו. גם שם של אדם יורה על עקר מציאותו שהוא הצדיק והרשע. ואם כינו אותו בשם אבותיו כוונתם שרוחו ונשמתו אליו יאסוף ולא יכרת שם המת מעל נחלתו ולא ימחה מישראל שמו.[ii]

Enosh onward,[1] weakness and frailty came into the world. He said in the name of his confidant that people would travel from one end of the world to the other, bringing silver, gold, and precious stones, and they made idols in the four directions, extending about a thousand parasangs. They would bring down the sun, moon, stars, and constellations to serve them in the manner they serve before the Holy One, blessed be He, for Shemchazai and Azael taught them all kinds of sorcery. Then the angels complained, saying, "What is man that You should remember him?" Therefore, they said that Enosh was the first to practice idolatry. The Divine Presence then ascended,[2] and thus the relationship between a person's name and his mazal should not surprise us.

The author of Neveh Shalom wrote in chapter 4, discourse 5, that the name indicates the essence. Consequently, a change of name indicates a change of essence. The author of Yefeh Mareh explained in Rosh Hashanah, chapter "The Court Saw Him," that this is why Rabbi Meir would interpret names, for how is it that the one who assigns the name would match it to the person's reality? As we say in the first chapter of Berakhot, "How do we know that the name is causative?" And as we see with the copper serpent that Moses made, the name agreed with its essential reality. A person's name also indicates his essential reality, whether he is righteous or wicked. And if they named him after his ancestors, their intention was that his spirit and soul would be gathered to him, so that the name of the dead would not be cut off from his inheritance, nor would his name be

[1] According to Genesis 4:26, it was in the time of Enosh (Adam's grandson) that 'people began to call upon the name of the LORD,' which rabbinic tradition sometimes interprets negatively as the beginning of idolatry, as referenced in this passage.

[2] This refers to the mystical concept that due to human sins, the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) withdrew or 'ascended' from earth, creating greater distance between humanity and God.

[i] Shemhazai and Azael are fallen angels mentioned in Jewish mystical literature, particularly in the Book of Enoch. According to tradition, they taught humans forbidden knowledge including magic and astrology, which led to increased wickedness in the world.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Introduction — The author is referencing that the Hashkavah prayer text appears at the beginning of Ma'avar Yabok, suggesting that this memorial prayer is so important that it was placed prominently at the start of the work. | Cf. Yalkut Shimoni — The author cites the Yalkut Shimoni to establish a mystical connection between names and souls, using Moses' census as evidence that names represent the essence of people's souls and can be used to count or identify them on a spiritual level. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Sanhedrin — This reference to the Jerusalem Talmud regarding Korah's rebellion shows that names have such spiritual potency that they can physically 'fly out' of written records when a person's spiritual status changes dramatically, further establishing the connection between names and souls. | Cf. Sefer HaAkedah (by Rabbi Isaac Arama) — The author cites this philosophical text to support the idea that cosmic

erased from Israel.

והגורל מה׳ כל משפטו.[i] ובשמזכיר
שמו במנוחה אחר מיתתו צריך
כוונה מפני שדבור התחתונים
פועל בעליונים מאד בסוד הבל
פה העולה[ii] כנזכר ובפרט אם
יזכר המת מבנו או מקרובו
ובבית הכנסת שהיה רגיל
להתפלל בו וכ״ש אם הוא בנה
אותה או הקדיש בה הקדשות
שהכל מסייע להשכין נשמתו
בענג שמתגלה באותו היום
קדוש על הנשמות קדושות וכמו
שהקדוש ב״ה מקדש נשמות
הצדיקים החיים כ״ש שנשמות
המתים ג״כ יקבלו מנוחה וענג
ובפרט על ידי התעוררות
המזכירים אותם: וברגלים מנהג
לעשות זכרון נשמות ונדבות
ביום טוב שני כי היום טוב שני
אנו עושים אותו לכבוד שכינה
שעמנו חוצה לארץ כדי שתתעכב
בעבורנו ההארה הנוספת ביום
טוב שני. כי להיותנו חוץ
מארצנו אנחנו צריכים הארה
יתירה וכמו שהאבות קיימו
התורה קודם שנתנה להשכין
שכינה עמם כן נהגנו אנחנו ביום

And the lot comes from the LORD—all of His judgment. When one mentions the name of the deceased in rest after death, proper intention is required[1] because the speech of those below powerfully affects the upper realms, through the mystery of the rising breath of the mouth as mentioned. This is especially true if the deceased is remembered by his son or relative, and in the synagogue where he regularly prayed—all the more so if he built it or dedicated sacred items to it. All these factors help to settle his soul in the delight that is revealed on that holy day upon the holy souls. Just as the Holy One, blessed be He, sanctifies the souls of the righteous who are alive, how much more so will the souls of the dead also receive rest and delight, particularly through the awakening caused by those who remember them.

On festivals, it is customary to perform memorial services for souls and make donations on the second festival day,[2] for we observe this second festival day in honor of the Divine Presence that accompanies us outside the Land of Israel, so that the additional illumination of the second festival day may linger for our sake. Being outside our land, we require additional divine illumination. Just as the Patriarchs observed the Torah before it was given in order to cause the Divine Presence to dwell with them, so too we observe the second festival day to cause the Divine Presence

[1] The Hebrew 'kavvanah' (intention) has specific technical meaning in Jewish mysticism, referring to focused mental concentration and specific mystical meditations that accompany ritual actions.
[2] This refers to the Yizkor (memorial) service performed on festivals in Ashkenazi communities and the accompanying custom of pledging charity in memory of the deceased.

changes (like a new star appearing) can result from human spiritual actions, which parallels his point about names and their power to influence mazal (astrological destiny). | Cf. Sefer HaTziyoni (by Rabbi Menachem Tziyoni) — This kabbalistic source is used to demonstrate the concept of 'awakening from below' (human actions affecting spiritual realms), connecting to the main theme that remembering the dead on Sabbath causes spiritual renewal for their souls. | Cf. Neveh Shalom (by Rabbi Abraham Shalom) — This philosophical work is cited to support the central mystical concept that names reflect essence, which is key to understanding why remembering the names of the deceased on Sabbath has actual spiritual effects on their souls. | Cf. Yefeh Mareh (by Rabbi Samuel Jaffe) — This commentary is cited to explain Rabbi Meir's practice of examining names, reinforcing the idea that names have causative power and can reflect or influence a person's spiritual reality.

[i] This opening phrase 'And the lot comes from the LORD—all of His judgment' is from Proverbs 16:33, establishing the theological premise that divine providence determines one's destiny, including in death.

[ii] This statement about 'the speech of those below powerfully affects the upper realms' reflects a fundamental kabbalistic principle regarding the cosmic impact of human speech, especially prayer and the recitation of divine names. The 'mystery of the rising breath' refers to the kabbalistic concept that the vapor or breath of speech ascends to higher worlds and creates effects there.

טוב שני להשכין שכינה עמנו
וזהו דשלחו מתם הזהרו במנהג
אבותיכם והנדבות והזכרת
נשמות זוכרים עמהם גם נפש
אברהם יצחק ויעקב שהרחיבו
גבול השכינה וכן נעשה אנחנו
ביום טוב שני והזכרת הנשמות
מוסיף אור למעלה[i] ולכן מנהג
הרוב להתנדב שמך לכפרת
הנפשות כי הנרות בכנסיות הם
מוסיפים ראיה והארה בנרות
שלמעלה דבוצינין מתדלקן
ונהורין נהרין[ii] וזהו העלאת
הנרות שאמור בהדלקת המנורה
במשכן ובמקדש כי היה מטיב
בבקר ובערב נרות עליונות
המכוונות נגד המנורה המאירה
נגדה ועוד שבנר על ידי הכלי
והפתילה והשמן והמים נעשה
היחוד מד׳ אותיות שבשם
ומאירים בכח החכמה שממנה
מוצא השמן והשלהבת למעלה
מהם רמז לקוצו של יו״ד[iii] על כן
הרוב מתנדבים שמן אף גם צדקה
אחרת זכות יחשב להם. וביה״כ
גם כן יש כפרה לחיים וגם למתים
כדאמרי׳ כפר לעמך ישראל אלו
החיים אשר פדית אלו המתים כי
בסוד לפני ה׳ תטהרו נכללים גם
בן נפשות המתים כי צנור הנעלם
מהכתר אל הבינה נפתח ביום

to dwell with us. This is the meaning of what they sent from there: "Be careful with the custom of your ancestors." When making donations and remembering souls, we also recall the souls of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, who expanded the domain of the Divine Presence,[1] and we do likewise on the second festival day.

The remembrance of souls adds light above, and therefore most people have the custom of donating oil for the atonement of souls, for the lamps in synagogues increase vision and illumination in the lamps above, as "lamps are kindled and lights shine forth." This is the "raising of the lamps" mentioned regarding the kindling of the Menorah in the Tabernacle and Temple, for one would prepare the upper lamps in the morning and evening, which correspond to the Menorah that shines opposite them. Furthermore, through the lamp vessel, the wick, the oil, and the water, a unification is made of the four letters of the Divine Name,[2] illuminating through the power of Wisdom from which the oil derives, while the flame above them alludes to the tip of the Yod. Therefore, most people donate oil, though other forms of charity are also considered meritorious.

On Yom Kippur, there is also atonement for both the living and the dead, as it is said: "Atone for Your people Israel"—these are the living; "whom You have redeemed"—these are the dead. For in the mystery of "before the LORD you shall be purified," the souls of the dead are also included, because the hidden channel from Keter to Binah[3] opens on that awesome

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the Patriarchs, through their righteousness and spiritual practices, created greater 'space' for divine manifestation in the world. The author suggests that commemorating the dead and giving charity similarly expands divine presence.

[2] This refers to the Tetragrammaton (YHVH), the four-letter divine name that in Kabbalah represents different aspects of divinity. The author is describing how the physical components of a lamp symbolically unify these divine aspects.

[3] In Kabbalah, Keter (Crown) is the highest divine emanation representing God's infinite will, while Binah (Understanding) represents divine comprehension and mercy. The 'hidden channel' between them allows the flow of divine compassion and forgiveness.

[i] The phrase 'adds light above' reflects the kabbalistic understanding that memorializing the dead creates actual metaphysical effects in higher spiritual realms, literally increasing divine illumination.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar means 'lamps are kindled and lights shine forth,' indicating how earthly rituals of lighting memorial lamps cause corresponding illumination in the celestial realms. The author is establishing a metaphysical correspondence between physical candles and spiritual light.

[iii] The 'tip of the Yod' refers to the smallest part of the first letter of the Tetragrammaton, which in Kabbalah represents Keter (Crown), the highest and most transcendent divine emanation. The author is suggesting that the flame of a memorial lamp reaches to the highest levels of divinity.

האדיר[i] ומתבשם הכל. ולכן נהגו להדליק נר כפרה לאביו ולאמו ביום הכפורים וכן לכל מתים ואין לכבות אותם במוצאי יום הכפורים: והצדקה תועיל למתים אם היה מנהג לעשות אותה בחייהם ואם ישלשנה מחיים ודאי כי יותר זכות תחשב לו שעל זה נאמר מצוה לקיים דברי המת:[iii ii]

day, and everything becomes fragrant. Therefore, it is customary to light memorial candles for one's father and mother on Yom Kippur, as well as for all the deceased, and one should not extinguish them at the conclusion of Yom Kippur. 170R

Charity benefits the dead if it was their custom to give charity during their lifetime. And if one designates charity while still alive,[1] it certainly counts as greater merit, as it is said regarding this: "It is a mitzvah to fulfill the words of the deceased." 175R

פרק כ״ד

Chapter 24

מצינו כי המתים מתפללים על החיים שכן כלב נשתטח על קברי אבות[iv] וממעשה שאירע לרבי אבא הובא בפ׳ שמות דף י״ו ע״ב[v] נראה זה ברור ששאל למת א׳ שהיה לחמא בר ליואי וא״ל ואתון ידעתון בצערא דחיי והשיב לו שר הקבר אי לאו בעותא דילן על חיי לא

We find that the dead pray for the living, as Caleb prostrated himself on the graves of the patriarchs. And from an incident that happened to Rabbi Abba, recorded in Parashat Shemot page 16b, this appears quite clear: he asked a deceased person who was Lachma bar Livai, saying to him, "Do you know about the suffering of the living?" The guardian of the grave replied to him, "If not for our prayers on behalf of the living,[2] they would not 5R

[1]The Hebrew term 'yeshalshena' (translated as 'designates') literally means 'triples it' or 'establishes it in three ways,' possibly referring to making a formal pledge, setting aside the funds, and ensuring their proper distribution.

[2]The original Aramaic phrase 'בעותא דילן' has connotations of both prayer and petition/request, showing the active intercession of the dead on behalf of the living.

[i]This refers to the kabbalistic concept that on Yom Kippur ('the awesome day'), a special channel opens between the sefirot of Keter (Crown) and Binah (Understanding), allowing for extraordinary divine mercy and forgiveness to flow. In this context, it explains why Yom Kippur has special power to benefit the souls of the deceased.

[ii]This is a rabbinic principle (Gittin 14b) that it is a religious obligation to fulfill the wishes of the deceased. Here it's used to emphasize the special merit of charity designated before death.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, section on Tzedakah — The author connects this passage to earlier discussions about the efficacy of charity in providing atonement and spiritual elevation for the deceased. | Cf. Zohar on the connection between earthly actions and upper realms — The reference to 'the speech of those below powerfully affects the upper realms' draws on fundamental Zoharic teachings about the cosmic impact of human actions, particularly in the context of prayer and remembrance of the dead. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Sukkah 55a — The passage refers to the rabbinic statement 'Be careful with the custom of your ancestors' which relates to observing the second festival day in the diaspora, showing how the author grounds mystical interpretations in traditional halakhic contexts. | Cf. Exodus 30:7-8 — The author draws a parallel between lighting memorial candles and the Temple service of kindling the Menorah, suggesting that memorial observances function as a form of Temple worship in post-Temple Judaism. | Cf. Yoma 87b — The passage interprets the verse 'Atone for Your people Israel... whom You have redeemed' to include both the living and the dead, suggesting that Yom Kippur has atoning power for souls in both realms.

[iv]This refers to a midrashic tradition about Caleb visiting the Cave of Machpelah in Hebron (the burial place of the patriarchs) to pray for divine assistance before speaking against the other spies. The biblical text (Numbers 13:22) only mentions that the spies went up to Hebron, but the midrash elaborates that Caleb separated from the others to pray at the graves.

[v]This reference is to the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism. In this passage, Rabbi Abba encounters a deceased person named Lachma bar Livai through the cemetery guardian and learns that the dead intercede for the living.

יתקיימון פלגות יומא וכבר נודע התעוררות המתים להתפלל בעד החיים בעת צרתם באמצעות ס״ת כשר המביאין אותו לבית הקברות על ידי בעלי תורה כאשר הובא בזהר פ׳ ויחי דף רכ״ה ובפ׳ אחרי מות דף ע״א אך צריך תשובה גדולה והכנות רבות וספר תורה כשר[i] יעויין שם וכן בליל הושענא רבה שבו חתימת חיי האדם כי בשמיני הוא חתימת הפרנסה ובלילה ההוא הנשמות יוצאות ומתפללות על החיים[ii] ושוטטות לשמוע הגזר דין ופעמים מודיעים לחיים בחלומות ובספר החסידים בסי׳ תנ״ב הביא מעשים על זה:[iii]

survive half a day."[1] It is already known that the dead are aroused to pray for the living in times of their distress through the medium of a kosher Torah scroll brought to the cemetery[2] by Torah scholars, as recorded in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi page 225 and Parashat Acharei Mot page 71. However, this requires great repentance, extensive preparations, and a kosher Torah scroll—see there for details. Similarly, on the night of Hoshana Rabbah, when the decree regarding human life is sealed[3] (for on Shemini Atzeret the decree regarding livelihood is sealed), on that night souls depart and pray for the living and wander about to hear the divine decree. Sometimes they inform the living through dreams, and in Sefer Hasidim, section 452, incidents of this are recorded.

מצאתי כתוב כי הנפש חונה בעצמות של מת ובזה נבין מה שאמרו חכמינו ז״ל באיזה עונות ותהי עונותם על עצמותם[iv] וכן

I have found it written that the soul dwells in the bones of the deceased,[4] and through this we can understand what our Sages of blessed memory said regarding certain sins: "And their iniquities shall be

[1] This striking claim emphasizes the essential nature of the dead's intercession for human survival, suggesting that the ongoing existence of humanity depends on this cosmic relationship between the living and the dead.

[2] This practice represents a ritual technology for activating communication between worlds. The Torah scroll serves as a channel or conduit that connects the living and the dead.

[3] The text presents a cosmic calendar where different types of divine judgments are finalized on specific dates. This theological framework structures Jewish ritual life around these cosmic moments when divine decrees can still be influenced.

[4] This is the central mystical claim of the passage—that the nefesh (lowest level of the soul) continues to reside specifically in the bones after death, rather than departing completely.

[i] The author emphasizes that bringing a Torah scroll to a cemetery to activate the intercession of the dead requires specific spiritual preparations. This both encourages the practice and sets boundaries around it to prevent misuse.

[ii] The night of Hoshana Rabbah (the seventh day of Sukkot) is traditionally considered a time when the decree for the coming year is finalized. The text elaborates on this with the mystical concept that souls of the departed actively participate in this cosmic process by interceding for the living.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shemot 16b — This Zohar passage provides the central evidence for the theological claim that the dead intercede on behalf of the living, suggesting an ongoing relationship between the worlds. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi 225 — This Zohar passage details the ritual practice of bringing Torah scrolls to graves to arouse the dead to intercede in times of community crisis. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Acharei Mot 71 — This passage complements the Vayechi reference, providing additional details about the proper protocols for cemetery rituals involving Torah scrolls. | Cf. Sefer Hasidim 452 — This medieval ethical work provides case studies supporting the theological claim that souls of the departed can communicate with the living, particularly through dreams. | Cf. The story of Caleb prostrating himself on the graves of the patriarchs — This reference to Caleb (likely based on a midrashic elaboration of Numbers 13:22) serves as a biblical precedent for the practice of seeking intercession from the deceased.

[iv] This appears to be a paraphrase of Ezekiel 32:27, "וְתִהְיֶ֥ינָה עֲוֹנֹתָ֖ם עַל־עַצְמוֹתָ֑ם" ("and their iniquities shall be upon their bones"), which the author interprets literally to mean that sins affect the bones because the soul resides there.

מה שאמרו עבירה קשורה
בו ככלב[i] ירצו כי נטרדים
עצמותיו על דרך גלגול עצמות
יהודה[ii] שהנפש היא הנכרתת
ממקורה. ובזה יובן ג״כ צער
גלגול מחילות[iii] שהיא לנפש
לבד שבהיות המתים בארץ
ישראל אז יושפע עליהם הרוח
שנאמר והבאתי אתכם אל אדמת
ישראל ונתתי רוחי בכם וחייתם
ויש קצת סיוע כי הנפש חונה
בעצמות ממה שספרו כי איש
אחד בא לפני שלמה לירש
ממון פלוני וגם אחר עמו שהיה
אומר שהוא בנו וגזר שלמה
שיקיזו שניהם דם ושיטבלו עצם
מעצמות המת בדם כל אחד מהם
ומאותו שנצבע העצם בדמו אמר
כי ודאי הוא בנו על דרך כי
הדם הוא הנפש. וכתוב בזהר
פ׳ תרומה דף קמ״א כי הנפש
נמצאת תוך הקבר כשהגוף בלוי
בעפר ואז מתגלגלת בעולם
ונמצאת בין החיים ויודעת צער
שלהם ומתפללת עליהם. ואמר
במקום אחר שכל זמן שהעצמות
הם באותו קבר הנפש נמצאת שם
והיא מתגלמת בדיוקן שהיא תוך
הגוף וכל עצמותיו בההוא דיוקן
עולים ומשבחים ומודים להקב״ה
הה״ד כל עצמותי תאמרנה ה׳
מי כמוך אומרות אינו אומר

upon their bones." Similarly, what they said that 30R
"sin is bound to him like a dog" means that his bones
are troubled, as in the rolling of Judah's bones, for
it is the soul that is cut off from its source. This
also explains the suffering of the "rolling of caves"
which applies only to the soul, for when the dead 35R
are in the Land of Israel,[1] then the spirit will flow
upon them, as it is said: "And I will bring you to the
land of Israel, and I will put My spirit in you, and
you shall live." There is some support for the idea
that the soul dwells in the bones from a story they 40R
tell of a man who came before Solomon to inherit
someone's property, and another was with him who
claimed to be the son of the deceased. Solomon de-
creed that they should both have blood drawn and
that a bone from the deceased should be dipped in 45R
the blood of each of them. From the one whose
blood stained the bon[2]e, Solomon declared that he
was certainly the son, based on the principle that
"the blood is the soul." It is written in the Zohar,
Parashat Terumah, page 141, that the soul remains 50R
within the grave when the body has decomposed to
dust, and then it wanders through the world and is
found among the living, knowing their suffering and
praying for them. And it says elsewhere that as long
as the bones remain in that grave, the soul is present 55R
there, and it takes form in the image that was within
the body,[3] and all his bones in that image rise up
and praise and thank the Holy One, blessed be He.
This is what is meant by "All my bones shall say:
LORD, who is like You"—it does not say "they say" 60R
but rather "they shall say." Therefore, it was the

[1] The text establishes a hierarchical geography of death, where burial in the Land of Israel confers spiritual advantages, including the reception of ruach (spirit) which those buried elsewhere do not receive without undergoing suffering.

[2] This story is a mystical expansion of Solomon's famous judgment involving the two mothers, but reconfigured to focus on the relationship between blood, bones, and soul essence. The blood staining the bone indicates a soul connection between father and son.

[3] The text describes a process where the soul creates a kind of spiritual body or form (diyokan) within the physical body during life, and this same form continues to exist in relation to the bones after death.

[i] This is a reference to a Talmudic statement (Sotah 3b) that sin clings to a person like a dog. The author reinterprets this metaphor to suggest that sin affects the soul's connection to the bones.

[ii] This refers to a Talmudic tradition (Makkot 11b) that Judah's bones rolled in his coffin due to his accepting responsibility for Benjamin. This tradition is repurposed here to illustrate how the soul's connection to the bones creates spiritual consequences.

[iii] The concept of 'rolling through caves' (gilgul mechilot) refers to a form of posthumous suffering described in rabbinic literature where the bodies of those buried outside the Land of Israel must roll through underground passages to reach Israel for the resurrection. The author uniquely specifies that this suffering affects only the nefesh (vital soul).

אלא תאמרנה.[i] ולכן מנהג החכמים לנענע עצמם[ii] בחיים בעת שאומרים שירות ובעסקם בתורה כי הוא שומרת האדם בקבר כדכתיב בשכבך תשמור עליך בקבר ואלמלא נתן רשות לעין לראות היה רואה בלילה שיוצא השבת ובלילי ראש חודש ומועדים כדיוקנאות על הקברות המודים ומשבחים להקב״ה. ובליל ר״ה כל הנפשות משוטטות ומתפללות על דין החיים וזהו סמך למנהג האשכנזים שהולכים ערב ר״ה להתפלל על הקברות[iii]

custom of the sages to sway their bodies during their lifetime when reciting songs and when engaged in Torah study, for this protects a person in the grave, as it is written: "When you lie down, it shall watch over you" [meaning] in the grave. And if permission were granted for the eye to see, one would see on the night following the Sabbath, and on the nights of the New Moon and festivals, forms above the graves giving thanks and praise to the Holy One, blessed be He. And on the night of Rosh Hashanah, all souls wander about and pray concerning the judgment of the living, and this is the basis for the custom of Ashkenazim who go to the cemetery on the eve of Rosh Hashanah[1] to pray at the graves.

ומנהג מיוסד על פי ותיקין הוא כדי לעוררם בכח התשובה שעושים שם להתפלל בלילה[iv] ונפש הזאת רואה הצל שנוטל ממונה א׳ עם אלפי אלפים ורבבות עמו בליל הושענא רבה דנפקין פתקין

And this is a custom established by the pious elders in order to awaken them [the deceased] through the power of repentance that is performed there, t[2]o pray at night. This soul [of the deceased] sees the shadow that is taken by an appointed angel with thousands upon thousands and myriads accompanying him on the night of Hoshana Rabbah, when the verdicts go

[1]The author provides a mystical explanation for the custom of visiting graves before Rosh Hashanah, suggesting that on this night souls are especially active in praying for the living who are about to be judged.

[2]The Hebrew is somewhat ambiguous about who is awakened—the dead souls or the living who visit the graves. Based on context, I've interpreted it as referring to awakening the dead souls through the power of the repentance performed by the living at their graves.

[i]The author is making a grammatical observation about Psalm 35:10. He notes that the verb is feminine plural ("תאמרנה"—"they shall say") rather than masculine plural ("יאמרו"—"they say"), which he interprets as evidence that the bones themselves actively praise God in the afterlife.

[ii]The author connects the traditional Jewish practice of swaying during prayer and Torah study (known as 'shuckling') to his mystical concept that movement of the bones during life prepares them for their spiritual role after death.

[iii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 141 — The author directly quotes this Zohar passage to support his claim about the soul's continued existence within the grave and its ability to move among the living and pray for them after the body has decomposed. | Cf. Psalms 35:10 — The author uses this verse to demonstrate that bones themselves have spiritual qualities, noting the precise wording 'shall say' (תאמרנה) which he interprets as indicating that bones literally praise God in the afterlife. | Cf. Story of King Solomon's judgment — This appears to be a midrashic expansion of the famous judgment of Solomon story, modified to focus on blood and bones as carriers of familial identity through the soul. The author uses this to support his claim about the soul residing in bones. | Cf. Ezekiel 37:12-14 — The author cites this prophetic passage about resurrection to support the special status of burial in the Land of Israel, where the spirit/ruach flows into the deceased, creating a higher spiritual state than burial elsewhere. | Cf. Proverbs 6:22 — The author reinterprets this verse about Torah study protecting one while sleeping to refer to how Torah study during life continues to protect the person after death 'in the grave.' This connects to his claim about bodily movements during study.

[iv]This likely refers to the Jewish custom of visiting graves before Rosh Hashanah and reciting prayers there. The author explains the mystical purpose behind this practice: the repentance performed at the graves awakens the deceased souls.

מבי מלכא[i] ומעלין אותו הצל
למעלה. ואחר ראייתה חוזרת
לקבר ומבשרת לשאר מתים
פלוני עתיד לבא גבן ואם צדיק
הוא כלם שמחים ואי לא אמרין
ווי שהדין מתגבר על שאר מתים
בבא אצלם רשע ולהפך בבא
צדיק הדין מיקל ע״כ אמרו
אוי לרשע ואוי לשכנו טוב
לצדיק וטוב לשכנו[ii] ושכנו יהיה
מלשון שוכני עפר הגם כי דברים
הם כפשטן ג״כ ואמרו שאותו
הצל מעלין אותו לעבד נאמן
מטטרו״ן[iii] והוא מעלה אותו
למקומו דכתיב כעבד ישאף
צל ומשם ואילך מתוקן מקום
לאיש ההוא בג״ע ומקום לנפש
לנוח וליהנות בעת שמשוטטת
והולכת לפי שיש נפשות שאין
להם מנוחה ועליהם כתיב
ונפש אויבך יקלענה בתוך כף
הקלע.[iv] שאין לה מנוחה יומם
ולילה. וזהו עונש גדול מכל.
ויש נפש שנכרתת עם הגוף עליה
כתיב והכרתי אותה מקרב עמה
ואין לה זכר כלל ויש נפש שאינה
נכרתת עם הגוף אלא כריתתה
ממקום אחר עליה כתיב ונכרתה
הנפש ההיא מלפני[v] ואינה
שורה עליה הרוח ואונה יודעת

forth from the King's house,[1] and they elevate that shadow upward. After seeing this, it returns to the grave and announces to the other dead: "So-and-so is destined to come among us." If he was righteous, all rejoice; if not, they say, "Woe!" because judgment intensifies upon the other dead when a wicked person joins them, and conversely, when a righteous person arrives, the judgment is eased. Therefore they said, "Woe to the wicked and woe to his neighbor; good to the righteous and good to his neighbor." Here "neighbor" refers to the "dwellers in the dust," although these matters can also be understood literally. And they said that this shadow is elevated to the faithful servant Metatron, who elevates it to its place, as it is written, "As a servant longs for shade" (Job 7:2). From then on, a place is prepared in the Garden of Eden for that person, and a place for the soul to rest and enjoy when it wanders and travels, for there are souls that have no rest, about which it is written, "But the soul of your enemies He shall sling out from the hollow of a sling" (I Samuel 25:29), having no rest day or night. This is the greatest punishment of all. There is a soul that is cut off with the body, about which it is written, "I will cut it off from among its people"[2] (Leviticus 17:10), and it has no remembrance at all. And there is a soul that is not cut off with the body, but its severance is from another place, about which it is written, "That soul shall be cut off from before Me" (Leviticus 22:3). The ruach [spirit] does not rest upon it, and it has

85R 90R 95R 100R 105R 110R

[1] The Aramaic phrase 'דנפקין פתקין מבי מלכא' refers to the kabbalistic belief that on Hoshana Rabbah, the final divine judgments (represented as 'notes' or 'verdicts') are issued from the divine court.
[2] The text is describing the concept of 'karet' (spiritual excision), but distinguishes between two forms: complete annihilation versus a lesser form where the soul continues to exist but is cut off from divine presence.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic belief that on Hoshana Rabbah (the seventh day of Sukkot), the divine verdicts that were sealed on Yom Kippur are 'sent out' from the divine court. The Aramaic phrase 'נפקין פתקין מבי מלכא' literally means 'notes/verdicts go forth from the King's house.'
[ii] This is a Talmudic saying (Sanhedrin 103b) originally referring to how neighbors influence each other in life. Here it's creatively reapplied to the realm of the dead, suggesting that souls buried near each other affect each other's spiritual condition.
[iii] In Jewish mysticism, Metatron is considered the highest of angels, often described as God's 'faithful servant.' The text suggests that the spiritual 'shadow' or essence of a person is first brought to Metatron, who then elevates it to its proper place in the afterlife.
[iv] This quotes 1 Samuel 25:29, which contains both the negative fate ('being slung from the hollow of a sling') and the positive fate ('being bound in the bundle of life') that the author uses to contrast the destinations of wicked and righteous souls.
[v] The text distinguishes between two forms of 'karet' (spiritual excision): complete annihilation where the soul is cut off with the body, and a lesser form where the soul continues to exist but is cut off from divine presence and higher spiritual awareness.

מדברים של מעלה כלל והיא
בנפש הבהמות ואין לה מנוחה
ובהליכתה פוגשת בממונה
הנזכר עם חיילותיו ומראים
לה כבוד הצדיקים וכבוד רוח
שלה ומתדבקת בו במנוחה
תוך מלבוש הרוח ואז יודעת
מדברים של מעלה וכשאותו
רוח עולה להתעטר תוך הנשמה
עליונה למעלה מתקשרת עמו
ומאירה ממנו כירח המאיר מן
השמש ורוח מתקשר תוך נשמתו
ונשמה מתקשרת בסוף המחשבה
שהיא סוד נפש למעלה ואותו
נפש מתקשרת בתוך ההוא רוח
עליון ואותו רוח מתקשר תוך
נשמה עליונה ואותה נשמה
מתקשרת בא״ס ואז הוא נייחא
וקשורא דכלא מעלה ומטה בסוד
אחד[i] ואז הוא נייחא לנפש למטה
ועל זה כתוב והיה נפש אדוני
צרורה בצרור החיים את ה׳
אלהיך בסוד וקשר אחד[ii]

no knowledge whatsoever of heavenly matters, being like the soul of animals. It has no rest, and in its wandering it encounters the aforementioned appointed angel with his hosts, who show it the glory of the righteous and the glory of its own ruach. It cleaves to it in rest within the garment of the ruach, and then it knows of heavenly matters. And when that ruach ascends to be crowned within the supernal neshamah [higher soul] above, it [the nefesh/lower soul] becomes bound with it and illuminated by it, like the moon that shines from the sun. The ruach binds within its neshamah, and the neshamah binds to the end of thought,[1] which is the mystery of the supernal nefesh, and that nefesh binds within that supernal ruach, and that ruach binds within the supernal neshamah, and that neshamah binds to the Infinite (Ein Sof). Then there is rest and binding of everything above and below in one secret,[2] and then there is rest for the nefesh below. Concerning this it is written, "May the soul of my lord be bound in the bundle of life with the LORD your God" (I Samuel 25:29), in the secret of one binding.

[1] This complex description of soul components binding together reflects kabbalistic conceptions of the hierarchical structure of the soul and its reunification after death. The 'end of thought' (סוף המחשבה) refers to a high spiritual level where divine thought transitions into manifestation.

[2] The phrase 'קשורא דכלא' (binding of all) refers to the ultimate kabbalistic goal of unifying all levels of existence. The 'one secret' (סוד אחד) refers to the fundamental unity underlying apparent diversity in creation.

[i] This describes the ultimate spiritual achievement in kabbalistic thought: the unification of all levels of existence ('above and below') into a single harmonious whole ('in one secret'). This concept of cosmic unity is central to kabbalistic theology.

[ii] Cf. I Samuel 25:29 — This biblical verse is used to establish the concept of 'tzror ha-chayyim' (the bundle of life), a metaphor for the soul's ultimate connection to the divine source after death. The author cites this verse twice—once negatively (souls of enemies being slung from the sling) and once positively (righteous souls being bound up with God). This verse became a cornerstone of Jewish mourning practices and appears on many traditional tombstones. | Cf. Job 7:2 — The author creatively reinterprets this verse, which in its original context describes a laborer longing for shade as relief from work. Here it's given a mystical interpretation where the 'shade/shadow' (צל/tzel) represents the soul's spiritual image, and the verse is used to describe how Metatron elevates this 'shadow' or spiritual essence to its proper place after death. | Cf. Zohar — The complex description of how the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah interact and bind together after death draws heavily from Zoharic conceptions of the soul's structure. Particularly Zoharic is the idea that the three soul components can be separated after death, with the nefesh remaining near the grave, the ruach ascending to lower Gan Eden, and the neshamah rising to higher spiritual realms, yet all maintaining a connection. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Sanhedrin 103b — This is a Talmudic saying that originally referred to the living, warning about the influence of bad neighbors. The author creatively reapplies it to the realm of the dead, suggesting that the proximity of souls in the afterlife affects their spiritual condition—righteous souls bring relief to neighboring souls, while wicked souls intensify judgment on those buried nearby. | Cf. Hoshana Rabbah traditions — This references Jewish mystical traditions about Hoshana Rabbah (the seventh day of Sukkot) as a final day of judgment when the verdicts sealed on Yom Kippur are actually 'delivered.' The text extends this tradition to suggest that these verdicts also determine the fate of souls in the afterlife.

ועד״ז בירידתם מלמעלה למטה
הירח ב״י שהיא נפש עליונה
המאירה לארץ ולדרים[i] היא
מלאה ומאירה מכל מחנות
ומרכבות עליונות ועושה מכלם
גוף אחד שלם המאיר כאור וזיו
עליון וזה ירמוז לעשר נצוצות
מאור המלכות המתפשטות
להחיות עולם הבריאה המאירה
מאור עליון בדמיון זה[ii] יורדות
נפש התחתונה מאירה מכל צדדין
מתוך אור הנשמה ומתוך אור
של הרוח ויורדת ומאירה לכל
מרכבות ומחנות שהם אברים
ועצמות[iii] ועושה אותם גוף
שלם המאיר כאור עליון מצד
צורת הדיוקן שלו שהוא צל
מהעליונים הדא הוא דכתיב
והשביע בצחצחות נפשך[iv] נפש
ממש ואחר כך ועצמותיך
יחליץ שעושה מהם בקבר גוף
שלם ומאיר כאור עליון והוא
קם ומודה ומשבח להקב״ה
כדאמרי׳ מפסוק כל עצמותי
תאמרנה[v] וזהו ניוחא לנפש מכל
הצדדין:[vi]

Similarly, in their descent from above to below, the moon—which is the Community of Israel (Knesset Yisrael),[1] the supernal soul that illuminates the earth and its inhabitants—is filled with and radiates light from all the celestial camps and chariots, forming from them all a single, complete body that shines with supernal light and radiance. This alludes to the ten sparks from the light of Malkhut[2] (Kingdom) that extend to enliven the World of Beriah[3] (Creation), which shines from the supernal light. In like manner, the lower soul descends, illuminated from all sides by the light of the neshamah (higher soul) and the light of the ruach (spirit),[4] and descends to illuminate all the chariots and camps, which are the limbs and bones, making them into a complete body that shines like supernal light through the form of its image, which is a shadow of the higher realms. This is what is written: "And He will satisfy your soul with radiance" (Isaiah 58:11)—literally the soul—and afterward, "and strengthen your bones," meaning that He makes them into a complete body in the grave that shines like supernal light. And it rises and acknowledges and praises the Holy One, blessed be He, as we learn from the verse, "All my bones shall say"[5] (Psalms 35:10). This is the satisfaction

135R 140R 145R 150R 155R 160R

[1]The Hebrew term '״כ' is an abbreviation for 'Knesset Yisrael' (Community of Israel), which in Kabbalah represents the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah) and is symbolically associated with the moon receiving light from the sun (representing masculine divine aspects).

[2]In Kabbalah, Malkhut (Kingdom) is the tenth and lowest of the divine emanations (sefirot), representing the divine presence in the material world. The 'ten sparks' refer to fragments of divine light that animate creation.

[3]Beriah is the second of four spiritual worlds in Kabbalah (below Atzilut/Emanation and above Yetzirah/Formation and Asiyah/Action), representing the realm of divine Creation where the highest souls reside.

[4]Kabbalah describes the soul as having multiple levels: neshamah (highest level), ruach (middle level), and nefesh (lowest level). Each corresponds to different spiritual worlds and divine attributes.

[5]The Hebrew actually uses the feminine plural form 'תאמרנה' (shall say) rather than the masculine

[i]The metaphor of the moon illuminating the earth parallels the kabbalistic concept of Malkhut (the divine feminine) receiving light from higher divine emanations and transmitting it to the lower worlds.

[ii]The author consistently employs the principle of correspondence between macrocosm and microcosm, showing how celestial patterns are mirrored in human spiritual anatomy.

[iii]In kabbalistic thought, the physical body parts correspond to spiritual entities and divine attributes, with the bones representing the most enduring connection to the divine structure.

[iv]The term 'tzachtzachot' (radiance/brilliance) in Isaiah 58:11 is interpreted in the Zohar as referring to the divine illumination that satisfies souls in the afterlife.

[v]This quotation from Psalms 35:10 is often used in kabbalistic texts to suggest that the physical remains maintain a spiritual consciousness even after death, capable of praising God.

[vi]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The author is adapting Zoharic concepts about the relationship between the divine feminine (moon/Community of Israel) and the human soul's components,

of the soul from all sides.

פרק כ״ה

Chapter 25

ממה שהעלינו מסולת נקיה מדברי חז״ל ראינו כי הצדיקי׳ זוכים לג׳ נייחות אחר מיתתם[i] דכבר אמרנו שהרוח נכנס בג״ע ומצטייר שם בדיוקן הגוף בעה״ז[ii] במלבוש שמתלבש שם ומתהנים שם בהנאות וכסופין דזיו דג״ע ובשבתות וחדשים ומועדים עולה למעלה ומתהנית שם וחוזרת למקומה ועל זה כתוב והרוח תשוב אל האלהים תשוב ודאי בזמנים אלו[iii] נשמה עולה מיד למקום שיצאה משם[iv] ומחמתה מתדלקת נר שהוא אור חדש כי יגיה בגינה למעלה וזו אינה יורדת למטה לעולם ועמה נכללת המדרגה העליונה שהיא בלולה מכל הבחינות מעלה ומטה שהיא

From the pure essence we have extracted from the words of our Sages of blessed memory, we have seen that the righteous merit three forms of rest[1] after their death. We have already stated that the ruach (spirit) enters the Garden of Eden and is formed there in the likeness of the body it had in this world, clothed in a garment in which it is dressed there. There, it delights in the pleasures and longings of the radiance[2] of the Garden of Eden. On Sabbaths, new moons, and festivals, it ascends higher and enjoys itself there before returning to its place. Concerning this it is written, "And the spirit returns to God who gave it" (Ecclesiastes 12:7)—it certainly returns during these times.[3] 5R 10R

The neshamah (higher soul) immediately ascends to the place from which it originated, and because of it, a lamp is kindled, which is a new light that illuminates above because of it. This never descends below, and with it is included the highest level, which 15R

form, which the author interprets as evidence that the bones themselves actively speak praises, not merely metaphorically.

[1]The Hebrew 'niyachot' (נייחות) has connotations beyond mere rest, suggesting spiritual satisfaction, proper placement, and fulfillment of purpose.

[2]The phrase 'הנאות וכסופין דזיו' combines technical kabbalistic terminology with more accessible language. 'Kisufin' (longings/desires) in kabbalistic contexts refers to spiritual yearnings rather than physical desires.

[3]I've emphasized the word 'certainly' to capture the Hebrew 'ודאי' which indicates the author is offering a specific interpretation of the biblical verse that differs from its common understanding.

showing how the metaphysical structure of the cosmos is mirrored in human spiritual anatomy. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — The author interprets this prophetic verse as a mystical reference to how the divine light fills and satisfies the soul, which then illuminates and strengthens the physical remains even in the grave. | Cf. Psalms 35:10 — The author uses this psalm verse to demonstrate that even after death, the physical remains maintain a connection to the soul and participate in spiritual activities like praising God. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author is drawing on the Tikkunei Zohar's teachings about how the different levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) correspond to different divine attributes and how they function together in life and after death.

[i]The concept of 'three forms of rest' (shalosh niyachot) reflects the kabbalistic understanding that each of the three soul components (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) requires its own specific form of spiritual repose after death.

[ii]This describes the kabbalistic concept that the ruach retains a form resembling its earthly body while in the Garden of Eden, maintaining a connection to its previous physical existence.

[iii]The author is offering a mystical interpretation of Ecclesiastes 12:7, suggesting that the biblical phrase about the spirit returning to God refers specifically to the temporary ascents of the ruach during sacred times rather than a permanent return.

[iv]According to kabbalistic tradition, the neshamah originates from the highest divine realms and returns there immediately after death, unlike the other soul components that have intermediate destinations.

מלכות שמים.[i] ועד שהנשמה עולה להתקשר במקומה הרוח אינו מתעטר בעטרותיו בג״ע של מטה והנפש אינה מתיישבת במקומה ובעלייתה לכלם יש נייחא. וכשבני העולם בצער והולכים לבית הקברות[ii] הנפש מתעוררת ומשוטטת ומעוררת לרוח והרוח מעורר לבחינת האבות שבג״ע ועולה ומעורר לנשמה ואז הקב״ה מרחם על העולם וכשהנשמה מתעכבת מלעלות למקומה הרוח עומד לפתח ג״ע ואינם פותחין לה ומשוטטת משם בעולם[iii]

encompasses all aspects above and below, which is the Kingdom of Heaven.[1] 20R

Until the neshamah ascends to be bound in its place, the ruach is not crowned with its crowns in the lower Garden of Eden, and the nefesh (vital soul) does not settle in its place. When it ascends, all [soul components] find rest. 25R

When people on earth are in distress and go to the cemetery, the nefesh is aroused and wanders about, stirring the ruach, and the ruach arouses the aspect of the Patriarchs who are in the Garden of Eden.[2] It then ascends and awakens the neshamah, and then the Holy One, blessed be He, has mercy on the world. When the neshamah is delayed from ascending to its place, the ruach stands at the entrance to the Garden of Eden, but they do not open for it, and it wanders from there throughout the world. 30R 35R

ואין מי שישגיח בה כמו שבני אדם אינם משגיחין בעה״ז על מעשה המצות וכן הנפש משוטטת בעולם ורואה הגוף המעלה תולעים ובאותו הדין ונפשו עליו תאבל וכל זה הוה על צד העונש. ועד שהנשמה מתקשרת במקומה נפש אין לה אור מעצמה

And none pay attention to it, just as people in this world do not pay attention to the performance of commandments. Similarly, the soul wanders in the world and sees the body producing worms, and in that judgment, "his soul mourns over him."[3] All this occurs as a form of punishment. 40R

Until the neshamah (higher soul) becomes bound to its place, the nefesh (vital soul) has no light of its

[1] This translates 'מלכות שמים' (Malkhut Shamayim), which in kabbalistic contexts specifically refers to the tenth and lowest sefirah (divine emanation), representing the divine feminine and the interface between higher realms and our world.

[2] The 'aspect of the Patriarchs' (בחינת האבות) refers to the spiritual presence or soul-roots of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, who according to kabbalistic tradition reside in the Garden of Eden and serve as intercessors for their descendants.

[3] This is an allusion to Job 14:22: 'But his flesh upon him shall have pain, and his soul within him shall mourn.' The verse is used in rabbinic literature to suggest the continued awareness of the soul after death.

[i] Malkhut Shamayim (Kingdom of Heaven) is both a theological concept referring to God's sovereignty and a technical kabbalistic term for the lowest of the ten divine emanations (sefirot), which serves as the interface between divine and human realms.

[ii] This passage provides a kabbalistic justification for the Jewish practice of visiting graves during times of communal distress, explaining the metaphysical mechanism by which such visits can activate divine mercy.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — This passage closely follows Zoharic teachings about how the three soul parts (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) relate to each other after death, with the nefesh remaining connected to the grave, ruach entering the lower Garden of Eden, and neshamah ascending to the highest realms. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 12:7 — The author interprets this verse kabbalisticallyto describe how the ruach (spirit) component of the soul temporarily ascends to higher realms during holy times before returning to its normal post-death resting place. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 3 — The text refers back to its own earlier explanations of the soul structure with "we have already stated," creating internal coherence within the book. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The description of how cemetery visits by the living create a chain reaction through the soul parts resembles Tikkunei Zohar's explanations of how earthly actions affect higher worlds.

כלום והיא המשתתפת בגוף
לזונו ולענגו בכל מה שצריך
כד״א ותתן טרף לביתה. בית
הוא הגוף ונערותיה הם אברי
הגוף רוח רוכב על נפש זו
לשלוט עליה ומאירה בכל מה
שצריך ונפש היא כסא לו[i] נשמה
שולטת ומאירה לרוח מאור
החיים שבמלכות ועד שהנשמה
העליונה אינה עולה תוך מקור
עתיקא דעתיקין סתימא דכל
סתימין[ii] ומתמלאת ממנו תדיר
בלא הפסק הרוח לא נכנס בג״ע
והנפש העליונה אינה מתישבת
במקומה תוך הגוף למטה הכי
נמי מתפרשן בבר נש וכיון שכלם
קשור אחד נשמה עולה למעלה
תוך מקור הבאר. רוח נכנס בג״ע
כדוגמת העליון. ונפש מתיישבת
תוך הגוף בקבר. ונפש שלמעלה
המתיישבת תוך הגוף תוך ההיא
קליפה קשה זהו נקרא קבר
עליון ועד״ז נפש תחתונה למטה
בקבר תחתון וכל עת שהעצמות
נמצאים תוך הקבר נפש זו נמצאת
שם.[iii] וכבר אמרנו איך מתעלית
נפש זו לשבח קב״ה בשבתות
וי״ט ור״ח[iv] בדיוקא הגוף עם
העצמות. ובעוד האדם חי אמרו
בתקון ס״ט דף ק״ט דרוח יורדת

own whatsoever. It is that which participates with the body to nourish and delight it in all that it needs, as it is written: "She provides food for her household."[1] The "house" is the body, and "her maidens" are the limbs of the body. The ruach (spirit) rides upon this nefesh to rule over it and illuminates it in all that is necessary, and the nefesh is like a throne for it. The neshamah rules and illuminates the ruach from the light of life that is in Malkhut (Kingdom).

Until the supernal neshamah ascends into the source of the Ancient of Ancients, the Most Hidden of all Hidden Ones, and is continuously filled by Him without interruption, the ruach does not enter the Garden of Eden, and the supernal nefesh does not settle in its place within the body below. So too are they separated in a human being.

And since they are all bound as one: the neshamah ascends above into the source of the Well; the ruach enters the Garden of Eden like its supernal counterpart; and the nefesh settles within the body in the grave. The nefesh above that settles within the body, within that hard shell,[2] is called the supernal grave, and in this manner, the lower nefesh is below in the lower grave. As long as the bones remain within the grave, this nefesh is present there.

We have already explained how this nefesh elevates itself to praise the Holy One, blessed be He, on Sabbaths, festivals, and new moons, in the exact form of the body with the bones. While a person is still alive, they said in Tikkun 69, page 109,[3] that the

[1] This is a direct quote from Proverbs 31:15, part of the 'Woman of Valor' (Eshet Chayil) passage. The author uses this verse metaphorically to describe the nefesh's role in maintaining the body.
[2] The term 'kelipah' (shell) in Kabbalah often refers to negative spiritual forces, but here it seems to refer to the physical body itself as a kind of shell or vessel that contains the soul, reflecting the Neoplatonic influence on Kabbalah where physical matter is considered a denser, more limited form of reality.
[3] This refers to the Tikkunei Zohar, a section of the Zoharic literature consisting of seventy 'tikku-

[i] The metaphor of one soul component being a 'throne' or 'seat' for another reflects the kabbalistic concept of hierarchical spiritual worlds, where each level serves as a vessel or container for the divine influence flowing from above.
[ii] These terms refer to the highest conceivable divine configuration in Kabbalah, sometimes identified with Keter (Crown) or even beyond. The text suggests that the soul's highest component (neshamah) ultimately reunites with this supreme divine source.
[iii] The text establishes that the nefesh (vital soul) remains with the bones in the grave as long as they exist there. This reflects the Jewish belief in a continued connection between the body and soul even after death, which is why proper burial practices are so important.
[iv] According to this kabbalistic teaching, the soul components experience temporary elevations during sacred times. This belief explains customs of reciting memorial prayers on Sabbaths and festivals, as these are considered especially auspicious times when the souls of the deceased can experience spiritual elevation.

ועולה בגוף ומתפשטת בכל
ורידי הלב המנענעים הה״ד אל
אשר יהיה שמה הרוח ללכת ילכו
אבל הנפש קבועה בלב כאשה
הקבועה בביתה[i] ושם אמר כי
השקרים גורמים סלוק שכינה
מעל האדם. וראיה מפ׳ חלק
ממעשה דאיתרע בההוא אתרא
דשמיה קושטא[ii] שבאור פני מלך
חיים.[iii]

ruach descends and ascends in the body and spreads through all the pulsating veins of the heart. This is what is meant by the verse: "Wherever the spirit would go, they would go."[1] But the nefesh is fixed in the heart like a woman fixed in her house. And there it is said that falsehoods cause the Divine Presence to depart from a person, as evidenced in the chapter Chelek from the story that occurred in that place called Kushta (Truth), for "in the light of the king's countenance is life."[2]

וכתוב בספר החסידים בסי׳
תתשל״ו כי הנפש היא במיתה
כמו בחיים וזהו שאמרו חז״ל
שהבועל שפחה חרופה נקשרים
יחד[iv] והביא שם מעשה מאחד
שלא ראה צל על ראשו בליל

And it is written in Sefer Hasidim, section 1736,[3] that the soul in death is like in life, and this is what our Sages meant when they said that one who has relations with a betrothed maidservant remains bound together with her.[4] He brings there a story about someone who did not see

nim' or rectifications. This specific citation shows the author's familiarity with these texts and their pagination in editions available to him.

[1]This quotes Ezekiel 1:20, from the prophet's vision of the divine chariot. The original context describes the movement of the chariot's wheels in harmony with the animating spirit, repurposed here to describe the relationship between the ruach and the body's circulatory system.

[2]This is a quote from Proverbs 16:15, used here to emphasize how truth (Kushta) and divine presence are connected, with the implication that the Divine King's favorable countenance brings life, while His absence (caused by falsehood) brings death.

[3]Sefer Hasidim (Book of the Pious) is a medieval ethical work attributed to Rabbi Judah the Pious (c. 1150-1217). It contains pietistic teachings and customs of the Ashkenazi Hasidim of medieval Germany.

[4]This refers to a specific legal category in Jewish law (shifchah charufah) and the spiritual consequences of such a relationship. The author uses this as evidence that spiritual bonds persist after death.

[i]The comparison of the nefesh to a woman fixed in her house while the ruach moves freely reflects gender dynamics of the period, but also establishes a kabbalistic metaphor where the feminine principle (often associated with Malkhut/Kingdom) is relatively stationary while the masculine principle (often associated with Tiferet/Beauty) is more mobile.

[ii]This refers to the Talmudic story (Sanhedrin 97a) about a town called Kushta where no one ever told a lie, and as a result, no one died prematurely. The author uses this to illustrate how moral behavior (truthfulness) affects spiritual reality (divine presence).

[iii]Cf. Proverbs 31:15 — The author draws on the imagery of the 'woman of valor' from Proverbs to describe how the nefesh tends to the body's physical needs, establishing a correspondence between spiritual and physical realms. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:20 — The author draws a parallel between the divine chariot's wheels that move according to the spirit's direction and the relationship between the ruach (spirit) and the body's circulatory system, suggesting that physical functions mirror spiritual patterns. | Cf. Proverbs 16:15 — The author connects the concept of truth (Kushta) with divine presence, suggesting that honesty maintains the connection between human and divine realms, while falsehood causes separation. | Cf. Zohar, Tikkun 69 — The author grounds his mystical explanation of soul dynamics in authoritative kabbalistic texts, specifically the Tikkunei Zohar, to establish the relationship between the ruach and physical processes like blood circulation. | Cf. Sanhedrin, Chapter Chelek — The author draws on a well-known Talmudic narrative about a place where truth was absolute to emphasize how falsehood disrupts the connection between humans and the divine presence, creating a spiritual parallel to the soul's disruption after death.

[iv]This refers to a type of spiritual bond that forms between individuals through certain actions. A 'shifchah charufah' is a specific legal category in Jewish law: a maidservant who has been designated for marriage to a specific man but has not yet been fully freed.

הושענא רבא[i] והתענה הוא ואוהביו צומות הרבה ופיזר נתן לאביונים בשפע וחי. גם מזה יראה כי תעניות אוהביו ורעיו של אדם מסייעים אותו להעביר מעליו הגזרה מהטעם שכתבנו. עוד אמרו כי לנשמות יש להם ספרים ערוכים על השלחן וכמו שרגילים בחייהם ללמוד כן לומדים במותם וכבר נתראה למשכילי עמנו דוגמא מזה ועיין לקמן בשם ספר הזהר מהו סוד השלחן של צדיקים בג׳ רגלים.[ii] והרב יוצא לקראת התלמוד במותו[iii] ולכן אמרו באותו תלמיד שנתחייב שריפה למקום הניחו לו שאדם גדול שמש כנראה מדברי הגמרא ואולי אז ר׳ יוחנן אחז ביד אלישע אחר שבא לקראתו כי שנה תורתו והעלהו עמו לג״ע. והמתים שמחים במיתת החיים אוהביהם ומתפללים עליהם קודם מותם. וע״פ מה שאמרנו שהנפש היא בעצמות ומתראים בדיוקן שהיו בעה״ז ע״כ צריך ליזהר שיהיו כל אבריו עמו בקברו ובפרט אותם שאין להם חליפין. וראיתי נוהגים שאפי׳ שני הלסתות שאין

his shadow on his head on the night of Hoshana Rabbah,[1] so he and his friends fasted many fasts, and he generously scattered charity to the poor, and lived. From this too we see that the fasts of a person's friends and companions help remove the decree from him,[2] for the reason we have written. They further said that souls have books arranged on the table,[3] and just as they were accustomed to study during their lives, so do they study after death. Examples of this have already appeared to the wise of our people, and see below in the name of the Zohar what is the secret of the table of the righteous on the three festivals. The teacher comes forth to meet his student in death, and therefore they said of that student who was condemned to burning, "Leave him be, for he served a great man," as appears from the words of the Gemara. Perhaps it was then that Rabbi Yochanan took Elisha Acher by the hand[4] when he came to meet him, because he had taught his Torah, and raised him up with him to the Garden of Eden. The dead rejoice in the death of their beloved living ones and pray for them before their death. According to what we have said, that the soul resides in the bones and appears in the form they had in this world,[5] one must therefore be careful that all of one's limbs be with oneself in the grave, especially those that have no replacements. I have seen the practice that even the two jawbones, which have no replacements, are stored to be buried

[1] Hoshana Rabbah is the seventh day of Sukkot, considered a day of final judgment when divine decrees for the year are sealed. A folk tradition held that if one could not see their shadow on this night, it portended their death in the coming year.

[2] This reflects the Jewish theological concept that communal spiritual efforts can alter divine decrees against individuals, based on the interconnectedness of all Jewish souls.

[3] This metaphorical description suggests that souls continue their intellectual and spiritual pursuits after death, studying Torah in the afterlife in ways that parallel their earthly study habits.

[4] This refers to a Talmudic story about Rabbi Yochanan saving the soul of his teacher Elisha ben Abuya (called 'Acher'—'the other'—after he became an apostate) from punishment in the afterlife.

[5] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the lowest level of the soul (nefesh) remains connected to the physical remains after death, particularly to the bones, explaining the importance of proper burial of all body parts.

[i] This refers to a folk belief that on the night of Hoshana Rabbah (the seventh day of Sukkot), one could determine if they would die in the coming year by checking if their shadow appeared when standing in moonlight. The absence of a shadow was considered an ominous sign portending death.

[ii] This refers to a mystical concept from the Zohar about how righteous souls participate in spiritual feasts during the three pilgrimage festivals (Passover, Shavuot, and Sukkot). These 'tables' represent realms of spiritual nourishment in the afterlife.

[iii] This describes the kabbalistic belief that when a Torah scholar dies, his teachers from the heavenly academy come to greet him and escort him to his place in the afterlife, recognizing the continuation of the teacher-student relationship beyond death.

להם חליפין מצניעין אותם
להקבר עמהם וכ״ש אם מחמת
חולי הוצרכו לחתוך לו אבר
אם אפשר להם יקברוהו עמו
וראיה מדוד דאסיק רישיה לגבי
גופיה דאבשלום.[i] עוד אמרו כי
יש עת מיועד לרוחות להתאסף
יחד ואז פעמים קובלים זה
מזה כדאמרי׳ דלא נימא לרב
מילי עלי. ואמרו בירו׳ דסוטה
פרק ה׳ שאמר רבי אלעזר בן
עזריה לר״ע דאמר אליהו בן
ברכאל זה בלעם. אי לית הוא
עתיד להתווכח עמך. ואמרו
במסכת חגיגה פ״ג בגמרין על
אותו הרוג שהרג יהודה בן טבאי
שלא כדין ואחר שמת יהודה לא
היה קולו נשמע כמו שהיה נשמע
בכל יום שהיה משתטח על קברו
וא״ל רב אחא בריה דרבא לרב
אשי ממאי דילמא פיוסי פייסיה
או בדינא תבעיה. והמתים
מתווכחים בב״ד של מעלה
והצדיקים עושים ביניהם שלום.
וכשהמלאכים מקצת מחייבים
ומקצת מזכים כפי מה שפוסקת
עיר וקדיש שנקרא בגמרא רוח
פסקונית[ii] בן גוזרים מלמעלה.
ואמרו בפ׳ פקודי כי גבריאל
הוא שליח העה״ז ולכן הוא לבוש
הבדים שמתלבש בלבושי העה״ז
כמו שהנשמה מתלבשת לבושים
דוגמת העולם העליון כדי
לעמוד שם. וזה מעשיו מושכים
מאור זיו העליון לבוש ליראות
בו לפני קונו ומתוכו מסתכלים
באספקלריא המאירה[iii] לחזות
בנועם ה׳ כי להשיג אורות

with them, and all the more so if due to illness they needed to amputate a limb—if possible they should bury it with him. Evidence of this comes from David, who brought up Absalom's head to his body. They further said that there is a designated time for spirits to gather together, and sometimes they complain about each other, as we say, "Let him not say words about me to the teacher." And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sotah, chapter 5, that Rabbi Elazar ben Azariah said to Rabbi Akiva, who said that Elihu son of Barachel is Balaam: "Is he not going to argue with you in the future?" And they said in Tractate Chagigah, chapter 3, in our Gemara, regarding that person who was wrongfully killed by Judah ben Tabbai, that after Judah died, his voice was no longer heard as it used to be heard every day when he would prostrate himself on his grave. And Rav Acha son of Rava said to Rav Ashi: "How do you know? Perhaps he appeased him or pursued him in judgment." The dead argue in the heavenly court, and the righteous make peace between them. And when some angels find merit and some find guilt, according to what the "city and holy one"—called in the Gemara a "decisive spirit"—decides, so they decree from above. And they said in Parashat Pekudei that Gabriel is the messenger of this world,[1] and therefore he is clothed in linen, dressing in the garments of this world, just as the soul dresses in garments like those of the upper world in order to stand there. And one's deeds draw down a garment from the radiance of the supernal light, in which to appear before one's Creator, and through it they gaze into the illuminating lens to behold the pleasantness of the Lord, for to attain the supernal lights, garments are needed, as in "Behold, I come to you in the thickness of the cloud,[2] that the people may hear," and likewise Moses, "And Moses entered into the

[1] In Jewish angelology, Gabriel is associated with judgment and serves as an intermediary between divine and earthly realms, needing appropriate 'garments' to function in each domain.

[2] This quote from Exodus 19:9 describes God's appearance at Mount Sinai. The author uses it to

[i] This references an aggadic tradition that David had Absalom's severed head rejoined to his body for burial, emphasizing the importance of bodily integrity in Jewish burial practices.

[ii] This refers to a term from the Book of Daniel (4:10) describing an angelic being who renders decisive judgments. In rabbinic literature, this became associated with a specific type of celestial force that finalizes judgments in spiritual realms.

[iii] This is a rabbinic term for the highest level of prophetic vision, described as looking through a clear, illuminated lens (contrasted with 'aspaklaria she'einah me'irah,' a non-illuminating lens). It represents direct, unmediated spiritual perception of divine truth.

עליונות צריכים לבושים על
דרך הנה אנכי בא אליך בעב
הענן בעבור ישמע העם וכן משה
ויבא משה בתוך הענן ואחד
160 מתכליות בריאת העולם היה
להיות לבושים לאורות[i] והדרוש
רחב במקומו: [ii]

midst of the cloud." One of the purposes of the creation of the world was to be garments for the lights, and this topic is extensive in its place. 160R

פרק כ״ו

Chapter 26

אם היה לאדם לב רחב כשלמה
ויכול לעסוק בתורה בחייו
ולא שמש כל צרכו בפשיעתו
כשמתווכחין עמו באותו עולם
5 לא יבין לומר האמת באופן
שלא יודו לו בישיבה של מעלה
ולא יזכה לבא בהם. ואם אדם
טורח בזה העולם לדעת אעפ״י
שאין לו לב עתה יהיה לו לב
10 במתיבתא דרקיעא. וכתוב בפ׳
וישב דף קפ״ה ע״א אורייתא
לא אתנשי מדמיכי עפרא דהא
כדין ינדעון כל ההיא אורייתא
דשבקו כד יסתלקו מהאי עלמא
15 וכל מלין מזדבאן יתיר מכמה

If a person had a broad mind like Solomon[1] and could engage in Torah study during his lifetime but did not serve his needs properly through his negligence,[A] when they debate with him in that world, he will not understand how to speak the truth 5R
in a way that would gain him acknowledgment in the heavenly academy, and he will not merit to join them. However, if a person toils in this world to gain knowledge, even though he may lack understanding now, he will be granted understanding in the 10R
heavenly academy.

It is written in Parashat Vayeshev, page 185a: "Torah is not forgotten by those who sleep in the dust, for they will then know all the Torah they left behind when they depart from this world. And 15R

[A] Or: "but did not serve [his teacher/Torah] adequately due to his negligence" — The Hebrew phrase 'lo shimesh kol tzorko' is somewhat ambiguous. While my primary translation takes it to mean 'did not serve his own needs properly,' it could alternatively refer to not properly serving one's teacher or not adequately serving/attending to Torah study. This alternate reading might better fit the context of Torah scholarship.

illustrate how divine revelations require appropriate 'garments' or veils to be perceivable without overwhelming the recipient.

[1] The Hebrew term "lev rachav" (broad mind/heart) alludes to 1 Kings 5:9, which describes Solomon's God-given wisdom as "broadness of heart like the sand on the seashore."

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the physical world serves as a 'garment' or vessel for divine light, suggesting that materiality itself was created to contain and express spiritual energies in a form that could be perceived and interacted with.

[ii] Cf. Sefer Hasidim — The citation from Sefer Hasidim serves as a foundational authority for the idea that the soul maintains consciousness and activity after death, which is central to the author's argument about posthumous spiritual existence. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The Zohar reference supports the kabbalistic understanding of how souls navigate different spiritual realms through appropriate 'garments' or vessels, paralleling how angels like Gabriel must don appropriate 'clothing' to function in various realms. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sotah, chapter 5 — This reference supports the concept that souls maintain their intellectual identity and debates after death, suggesting a continuity of consciousness and relationships beyond physical life. | Cf. Tractate Chagigah, chapter 3 — This Talmudic story is used to demonstrate that the dead can be appeased or continue to pursue justice in the afterlife, supporting the book's central theme of continued spiritual agency after death. | Cf. Hoshana Rabbah custom of checking one's shadow — This alludes to the folk belief that not seeing one's shadow on Hoshana Rabbah night portends death in the coming year, connecting to Ma'avar Yabok's broader theme of preparation for death and spiritual transition.

דהוו בהאי עלמא דהא כל אינון מלין דאיהו לא יכיל לאדבקא לון בדקא חזי ואיהו אשתדל בהו כולהון עיילין במעוהי מתקנן ואורייתא תמלל ביה והיינו דכתיב והקיצות היא תשיחך. ושני מלאכי השרת מסדרין תלמודו של אדם בפניו בצאתו מן העולם שלא יהיה לו בושת פנים לפני הקב״ה כמו שדרשו על פסוק לא ירעיב ה׳ נפש צדיק. וא״כ אשרי העוסק בסודות התורה ובדברי רשב״י שכמו שטעם בעה״ז מעין עה״ב כן ישביעוהו מפרי מעשיו ותורתו ואמר מורי הגאון מפאנו זצ״ל כי שני מלאכים חלו הם יצ״ט ויצ״ה להיות כי הם שמעו מפיו תורה כל ימי חייו ונתקדשו שניהם על ידו[i] שמשך אותם לבית המדרש ואם במתן תורה אמר בתקון כ״ב שכל אחד מהמלאכים היה עושה עצמו קול ופורח באויר וכל אחד מישראל שהיה אומר נעשה ונשמע היה שורה בפיו ומלמדו התורה כלה כ״ש שהמלאכים גבורי כחו של האדם המתהוים מתורתו ומעשיו בחייו שלומדים ומבינים אותו בעצם מה שלמד והגה בעה״ז וזהו ליגרים איניש בעה״ז והדר ליסבר בעה״ב לגרוס איניש ואע״ג דלא ידע מאי קאמר כי עתיד להבין ואמרו האי מאן דבעי למנדע אע״ג דלא ידע שבחא איהו ליה כי מי שטרח ולא השיג יזכה ויבין בג״ע ולכן טוב לגרוס ספר הזהר ותקונים ור״מ וכיוצא גם שלא יבין אותם.[ii] ובתקון

all matters become more refined than they were in this world, for all those matters that one was unable to properly grasp, yet strove to understand[A]—all of them enter his inner being properly arranged, and the Torah will speak through him. This is the meaning of the verse, ‘When you awake, it shall converse with you’ [Proverbs 6:22].” 20R

Two ministering angels arrange a person’s learning before him when he departs from this world so that he will not be ashamed before the Holy One, blessed be He, as they interpreted the verse, “The Lord will not allow the soul of the righteous to hunger” [Proverbs 10:3]. 25R

Therefore, fortunate is one who engages in the secrets of the Torah and the teachings of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, for just as he tasted in this world a semblance of the World to Come, so will he be satisfied with the fruit of his deeds and his Torah study. My teacher, the Gaon of Fano, of blessed memory, said that the two angels—the good inclination and the evil inclination—are these, for they heard Torah from his mouth throughout his lifetime and were both sanctified through him, as he drew them into the house of study. And if at the giving of the Torah, as stated in Tikkun 22, each of the angels made itself into a voice flying through the air, and each Israelite who said “We will do and we will hear” had an angel rest upon his mouth teaching him the entire Torah—how much more so the angels, the mighty ones who do His bidding, who are formed through a person’s Torah study and deeds during his lifetime, will teach and help him truly understand what he learned and contemplated in this world. 30R 35R 40R 45R

This is the meaning of “a person should study in this world and afterward understand in the World to Come”—one should study even if he does not understand what he is saying, for he will understand it in the future. And they said: “Whoever wishes to know, even though he does not know, it is praise- 50R

[A] Or: “exerted effort in them” — The Aramaic phrase ‘ishtadal behu’ could be rendered more literally as ‘exerted effort in them,’ which preserves the sense of active striving without specifically limiting it to understanding. This alternate translation captures the broader sense of effort and engagement with Torah concepts.

[i] This striking passage teaches that even the evil inclination (yetzer hara) can be sanctified through Torah study, suggesting that when a person studies Torah, they elevate both their good and evil inclinations by bringing them into the house of study.

[ii] This reflects an important kabbalistic approach to sacred texts—that their recitation has spiritual value even without intellectual comprehension. The physical act of studying creates spiritual effects regardless of one’s understanding.

ל״ח אמרו שהדבור שנעשה מלאך היה לשמור בחינת רוחם שמכחו דבר עמהם הקב״ה מעולם דמטטרו״ן ועוד דבר עמהם מכח הנשמה שבכסא שבה יורד השכינה העליונה בלולה משלשה ספירות ראשונות[i] על זה נאמר מן השמים השמיעך את קולו. עוד דבר עמהם מאופן שמשם מוצא הנפש של אדם שעל זה נאמר ועל הארץ הראך את אשו הגדולה שכן עליו נאמר והנה אופן אחד בארץ. הנה כי קדש רוחניות התורה שירדה מהאצילות העליון עולם הכסא עם כל גדודיו ועולם המלאכים בכללו ושמים וארץ רוחניים מעולם העשיה ומשם לשמים וארץ גשמיים עד שהעבירה זוהמת עם בני ישראל וקדשם. והצדיקים זוכים לעטרה שעל ראשם לעה״ב מפני שטהרו המוח שבראשיהם כדי שתהיה השכינה מתעטרת עליהם. ושכר המצות הוא כפי מה שממשיכים אותם בני האדם במחשבתם אם עובד לכבוד ה׳ הקב״ה בעצמו ישלם שכרו ואם בשביל שכר העה״ז יש לו שכר מעין עה״ז ואם בשביל ג״ע שכרו על ידי עולם המלאכים המשמשים את הגן אבל העובד שלא ע״מ לקבל פרס שכרו מלמעלה ממקום אשר עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך ואין במצות למעלה מת״ת בנודע להיות כי בזה הוא אחוז בנוף אילן עץ החיים ואם לא עוסק בהם ויקחוהו וישליכו אותו הבורה וגו׳ ר״ל ופעמים בעה״ז נוצח שאינו צדיק לצדיק בפלפול כדי שיהיה לו עה״ז מלא. ופעמים

worthy for him," for one who toiled but did not attain will merit to understand in the Garden of Eden. Therefore, it is good to study the Book of the Zohar, the Tikkunim, and Ra'aya Mehemna, and similar works, even if one does not understand them. 55R

In Tikkun 38, they said that the speech that became an angel was to preserve the aspect of their spirit, through which the Holy One, blessed be He, spoke to them from the world of Metatron. Additionally, He spoke to them through the power of the soul in the Throne, wherein the supernal Divine Presence descends, encompassing the three first sefirot. Regarding this it is said, "From heaven He made you hear His voice" [Deuteronomy 4:36]. He further spoke to them through the Ofan, from which the human soul originates, concerning which it is said, "And on earth He showed you His great fire" [ibid.], for about it, it is said, "And behold, there was one Ofan on the earth" [Ezekiel 1:15]. 60R 65R 70R

Behold, the holiness of the Torah's spirituality descended from the supernal emanation, the world of the Throne with all its hosts, and the world of the angels in its entirety, and the spiritual heavens and earth from the world of Asiyah, and from there to the physical heavens and earth, until it removed the spiritual impurity from the children of Israel and sanctified them. 75R 80R

The righteous merit the crown upon their heads in the World to Come because they purified the brain in their heads so that the Divine Presence might be crowned upon them. The reward for commandments depends on how people channel them in their thoughts: if one serves for the glory of God, the Holy One, blessed be He, Himself will reward him;[1] if for the sake of reward in this world, he receives a reward similar to this world; and if for the sake of the Garden of Eden, his reward comes through the world of angels who serve the Garden. But one who serves without expecting a reward receives his reward from above, from a place of which "No eye has seen, O God, beside You"[2] [Isaiah 64:3]. And there 85R 90R 95R

[1] This passage reflects the rabbinic teaching from Pirkei Avot 1:3 about serving without expectation of reward, but adds a sophisticated kabbalistic framework of how intentions during mitzvah performance determine the source and nature of divine reward.

[2] This references Isaiah 64:3, traditionally understood as describing the incomprehensible nature

[i] This refers to the highest three sefirot (divine emanations): Keter (Crown), Chokhmah (Wisdom), and Binah (Understanding), which in Kabbalah represent the most transcendent aspects of divinity, beyond human comprehension.

כי הדור אינם זוכים בשמועות
דאדם צדיק בישראל שהיו
נשמעים לאחיתופל וכבר אמרו
דטינא היתה בלבו.[i] ואי לך
ארץ שמלכך מנוער מן המצות
דבתר רישא גופא אזיל ואשרך
ארץ שמלכך בן חורין מדינה
של גיהנם שהרב הדומה למלאך
ה׳ צבאות אז הוא מוכן לקבל
ממעינות של תורה עילאה ויכוין
ההלכה על האמת והצדק:[ii]

is no commandment higher than Torah study, as is known, because through this one clings to the foliage of the Tree of Life. If one does not engage in them, "they took him and cast him into the pit" [Genesis 37:24], etc.—that is to say, sometimes in this world, 100R
one who is not righteous defeats a righteous person in scholarly debate so that he may have his fill of this world. And sometimes the generation does not merit to hear the teachings of a righteous person, as in the case of Israel who listened to Ahithophel, 105R
though they already said that he harbored ill will in his heart.[A]

"Woe to you, O land, whose king is a youth" [Ecclesiastes 10:16]—who is immature in commandments, for the body follows the head. "Happy 110R
are you, O land, whose king is a free man" [ibid. 10:17]—free from the judgment of Gehenna, for the rabbi who resembles an angel of the Lord of hosts[1] is then prepared to receive from the wellsprings of the supernal Torah, and will direct the law toward truth 115R
and righteousness.

פרק כ״ז

Chapter 27

[A] Or: "he had a grudge/resentment in his heart" — The Hebrew term 'tina' specifically refers to a long-standing grudge or resentment. This alternative translation more precisely captures the nature of Ahithophel's feelings toward David according to rabbinic tradition.

of the reward reserved for the righteous in the World to Come. The author uses this to emphasize that the highest level of service receives reward from the most transcendent divine source.

[1] This alludes to Malachi 2:7, "For the lips of a priest should guard knowledge, and people should seek instruction from his mouth, for he is an angel/messenger of the LORD of hosts." The text reinterprets this verse to suggest that a truly worthy spiritual leader channels divine wisdom directly.

[i] This refers to the biblical account where King David's advisor Ahithophel joined Absalom's rebellion. The Talmud (Sanhedrin 106b) suggests he harbored resentment (tina) against David, illustrating how even the greatest wisdom can be corrupted by negative personal motivations.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Vayeshev 185a — This Zohar passage serves as a key textual proof for the author's assertion that souls retain and even enhance their Torah knowledge after death. The reference reinforces the idea that spiritual study in this world has permanent effects in the next world. | Cf. Proverbs 6:22 — The author reinterprets this verse, which originally refers to Torah guiding a person throughout life, to suggest that Torah knowledge becomes actively communicative through the soul after death. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — These references establish the metaphysical framework for understanding how human speech becomes angelic and how divine revelation works across multiple spiritual worlds. They support the author's claim about the importance of Torah study even when not fully understood. | Cf. Tree of Life — This is an allusion to the kabbalistic symbol of the Tree of Life (Etz Chaim), suggesting that Torah study connects one to the divine emanations (sefirot). The metaphor encourages the reader to contemplate how Torah study serves as a literal connection to divine reality. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 10:16-17 — The author reinterprets these verses that originally referred to political leadership to instead describe spiritual leadership and Torah knowledge, creating a contrast between communities led by the spiritually immature versus those guided by the spiritually advanced.

אין הקב״ה דן את האדם אלא
בפמליא של מעלה שלעולם
פותחין בזכות ולכן נקרא ההיכל
שבו הסנהדרין קדושים היכל
הזכות לא כן היכל שכנגדו
בקליפה הפותחים לעולם
בחובה וכשהקב״ה גומר הדין
אין מי שישיב עליו שנאמר
והוא באחד ומי ישיבנו:[i] ויש
עוד בקדושת ב״ד תחתון וב״ד
עליון ודין האדם הוא בעליון
דנפישי רחמיו. עוד אמרו כי
הנפש החוטאת היא תמות דצריך
למרק המשחית שעשה ביסורין
ותשובה מועלת ואינה מבטלת
הגזרה כולה אלא תולה היסורין
עד שיקבלם עליו מעט מעט
ובזה יתמוגג המשחית וגורמת
התשובה חלישת כח המקטרגים
ע״ד עת אשר שלט אדם באדם
אדם רע באדם דקדושה לרע
לו דאדם בליעל. והגר אחר
שירשה מקומה של שרה והקל
בעיניה ברחה ונתענתה תחת
ידיה וזהו כוונת אברהם באומרו
הנה שפחתך בידך וכוונת שרה
לענותה כי חששה שגבר עליה
כח הקדושה בביאת אברהם
ואמר לה כי לא לקטה רק
סריות שבו והראיה כי תכנע
ותשתעבד תחתיה שהיא בסוד
הקדושה ע״ב רצתה שרה לנסות
זה בענות אותה כי לא היה לה
כוונת נשים קלי דעת בענות
אותה. ודימו שליטת החצוני
בכח הקדושה לחיה גדולה שבלע

The Holy One, blessed be He, judges a person only in the company of the heavenly court, which always begins with merit. Therefore, the chamber where the Sanhedrin sits is called the "Chamber of Merit." Not so the corresponding chamber in the realm of impurity,[1] which always begins with guilt. And when the Holy One, blessed be He, finalizes judgment, there is no one who can respond to Him, as it is said, "He is One, and who can turn Him back?" 5R

There is also [a distinction] in the sanctity between the earthly court and the heavenly court, and human judgment takes place in the higher realm where His mercies are abundant. They further said that "the soul that sins shall die," meaning that one must purge the destructive force created [by sin] through suffering. Repentance is effective but does not nullify the entire decree—rather, it suspends the suffering until one accepts it little by little, and through this the destructive force dissolves.[2] Repentance causes the weakening of the accusers' power, as in "a time when man rules over man to his detriment," meaning a wicked person [ruling] over a holy person, to the detriment of the wicked one. 10R 15R 20R

This is like Hagar, who after inheriting Sarah's position,[3] looked lightly upon her, fled, and was then afflicted under her hand. This was Abraham's intention when he said, "Behold, your maidservant is in your hand," and Sarah's intention in afflicting her was because she feared that the power of holiness had strengthened in her through Abraham's coming to her. He told her that [Hagar] had gathered only the thorns within him, and the proof was that she would submit and be subjugated to Sarah, who embodied the mystery of holiness. Therefore, Sarah wanted to test this by afflicting her, for she did not have 25R 30R 35R

[1] The Hebrew term 'kelipah' (shell/husk) is a technical kabbalistic concept referring to the realm of impurity or negative spiritual forces that oppose holiness. I've translated it in a more accessible way while maintaining the contrast with the 'Chamber of Merit.'

[2] The text describes a spiritual process where repentance doesn't eliminate suffering entirely but transforms how it's experienced. The Hebrew term 'yitmogeig' (dissolves/melts away) suggests that the destructive spiritual entity created by sin gradually loses its power through the controlled acceptance of suffering.

[3] The text uses the biblical story of Sarah and Hagar as a mystical allegory for the interaction between forces of holiness (Sarah) and external forces (Hagar). This represents a typically kabbalistic reading where biblical narratives reveal deeper metaphysical principles.

[i] This references Job 23:13, 'But He is in one mind, and who can turn Him?' The verse is invoked to establish God's ultimate authority in judgment once a decision is finalized.

אדם מזויין[i] ולא חבלו בפיה להיותה גדולה הרבה וזהו סוד והלבנון באדיר יפול[ii] והאדם
40 הזה שלא חובל בפיה יש בידו חרב פיפיות וירד לתוך מעיה של חיה זו והחרב בידו ובעודו בתוכה משחית בני מעיה בחרבו הקשה הנה ששליטתה בו הוא
45 לרע לה בסוד ותבאנה אל קרבנה ומראיהן רע[iii] וגו׳ כמו כן התשובה גורמת חלישות כח במקטרגים. ולכן השב מאהבה יש לו שכר על כל עון כאלו
50 עשה שתי מצות הא׳ החטא עצמו שנתהפך למצוה ומלאך רע נעשה טוב הב׳ המלאך החדש המתהוה מהתשובה פרטית שעושה לכל עון וזהו כי לקחה מיד ה׳ כפלים
55 בכל חטאתיה.[iv] כפלים נחמות ולכן נחמו נחמו עמי. והתשובה גם שהיא מיראה מועלת היא לנשמה להביאה לעה״ב שהמיתה עם התשובה כפרה עליו ובזהר
60 פ׳ מקץ על פסוק ויראו האנשים דף ר״א ע״ב שם יש תוכחה לאדם שיזכור יום המות תמיד גם בתקונים כתב על פסוק יונה דרוש רחב על הנשמה והגלות
65 אשריהם הצדיקים שתמיד מרבים שמן לנר נשמתם ורוחם בעה״ז וזוכים לבנים במיתתם כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ וישב דף ק״מ ע״ב. ואמרו בזהר פ׳ תרומה דף קכ״ח ע״א
70 כי השתדלות התלוי במעשה המצות אסור ליקח אותו בחנם שרוח הקדש אינו נמשך על

the frivolous intentions of simple-minded women in afflicting her.

They compared the dominion of external forces over holiness to a great beast that swallowed an armed man without injuring him in its mouth, because it was so large. This is the secret meaning of "And Lebanon shall fall by a mighty one." This man, who was not injured in its mouth, has a double-edged sword in his hand, and he descends into the innards of this beast with the sword in his hand. While inside it, he destroys its inner organs with his sharp sword. Thus, its dominion over him is actually to its own detriment, as in the secret of "When they entered into their stomach, it could not be known that they had entered; their appearance was as bad as before." Similarly, repentance causes a weakening of the accusers' power. 40R 45R 50R

Therefore, one who repents out of love earns reward for each sin as if he had performed two commandments: first, the sin itself, which is transformed into a commandment, and a harmful angel becomes good; second, the new angel created from the specific repentance performed for each sin. This is the meaning of "For she has received from the hand of the LORD double for all her sins"—double consolations, and therefore "Comfort, comfort My people." 55R 60R

Repentance, even if motivated by fear, benefits the soul by bringing it to the World to Come, for death combined with repentance atones for him. In the Zohar, Parashat Miketz, on the verse "And the men were afraid" (page 201b), there is a rebuke for a person to always remember the day of death. Also in Tikkunim, on the verse about Jonah, there is an extensive discourse on the soul and exile. Fortunate are the righteous who always increase oil for the lamp of their soul and spirit in this world,[1] and merit chil- 65R 70R

[1] This uses the metaphor of a soul as a lamp requiring oil, drawing on the biblical imagery from

[i] This is a kabbalistic metaphor where the 'external forces' (forces of impurity) are compared to a large beast that swallows a person. The metaphor continues to explain that though the person appears to be overcome, they can actually defeat these forces from within through repentance.

[ii] This quotes Isaiah 10:34, 'And Lebanon shall fall by a mighty one.' In the kabbalistic interpretation here, Lebanon represents the forces of impurity that will ultimately fall through the action of the righteous.

[iii] This references Genesis 41:21 from Pharaoh's dream, where the thin cows devoured the fat ones yet remained as thin as before. It's used metaphorically to describe how negative forces cannot truly benefit from consuming holiness.

[iv] This quotes Isaiah 40:2, 'For she has received from the LORD's hand double for all her sins.' The author interprets this doubling positively as referring to double consolations, as reinforced by the next verse quoted ('Comfort, comfort My people').

האדם במעשה המצות אלא באגר שלים ואמר שכתוב בספר שלמד
75 אשמדאי לשלמה שכל מי שרוצה להעביר ממנו רוח הטומאה ולכסות רוח זרה ממנו כי צריך לקנות דבר הראוי לו לזה בכסף שלם ובהשתדלות רב וסגי שהוא
80 בטהרת משכנו ורצון לבו ולא שיטה לבו לימין ולא לשמאל ואם לאו הטהרה תתרחק ממנו ולא יהיה בידו כח לקנותה כבתחלה לפי שרוח הטומאה תזדמן תמיד
85 על הדבר שהוא חנם. ראה כמה גדול כחן של מעשה הצדיקים שאפי׳ זווג של ת״ח שאינם מולידים מתהוה מהם רוחות קדושות כדאמרו באברהם ושרה
90 וכמו כן זווג הנעשה בקדושה גם שאין אנו רואים הויה מוגלמת מהם. מהטפות ההם מתהוה כחות מוכנות להתלבש בהם ניצוצות הנדחים מהקדושה והכל לפי
95 הכוונה. והזווג שהוא עם אשתו קדושה בכוונה זכה יערה עליו רוח ממרום וידענו שהזווג שהוא להוליד כדומה נקרא בעילת קדושה והזווג שאין ראוי ללידה
100 בגון המניקה והמעוברת גם הוא לצורך גבוה ונקרא בעילת מצוה ולכן קראו כן לבעילה ראשונה שאיו האשה מתעברת ממנה ועיין בסי׳ י״ח וי״ט מאם כל חי מהגאון
105 מורי מפאנו[i] ושם תמצא כמה מיני יעודים מוכנים לצדיקים ושם דבר מסעודת לויתן ובסימן כ״א מדבר מבהמות בהררי אלף ובסי׳ כ״א מזיז שדי:[ii]

dren in their death, as is stated in Parashat Vayeshev, page 140b.

They said in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 128a, that effort related to the performance of commandments must not be taken for free,[1] because the holy spirit is drawn upon a person through performing commandments only with full payment. It says that in a book that Ashmedai taught to Solomon, anyone who wishes to remove the spirit of impurity from himself and to cover a foreign spirit from himself must purchase something suitable for this with full payment and with great effort. It is sufficient that he [do so] with purity of his dwelling and the will of his heart, not turning his heart to the right or to the left. Otherwise, purity will distance itself from him, and he will not have the power to acquire it as before, because the spirit of impurity is always ready to come upon something that is free.

See how great is the power of the righteous ones' deeds, that even the union of Torah scholars who do not produce children generates holy spirits, as they said regarding Abraham and Sarah. Similarly, a union performed in holiness, even if we do not see a tangible being produced from it—from those drops are formed powers ready to clothe themselves in the sparks that were pushed away from holiness, and everything depends on the intention. And the union with one's wife in holiness with pure intention causes a spirit from above to be poured upon him. And we know that a union intended for procreation is called a "holy union," while a union not appropriate for conception, such as with a nursing or pregnant woman, is also for a higher purpose and is called a "commandment union." Therefore, they also called the first act of intercourse by this name, since the woman does not become pregnant from it. See sections 18 and 19 of "Em Kol Chai" by my teacher, the Gaon of Fano, and there you will find several types

75R 80R 85R 90R 95R 100R 105R 110R

Proverbs 20:27 ('The spirit of man is the lamp of the LORD'). In kabbalistic thought, performing commandments and good deeds provides the 'oil' that illuminates one's soul.

[1] This reflects a kabbalistic principle that spiritual achievements require commensurate effort. The notion that holiness must be 'purchased' with 'full payment' shouldn't be understood literally as monetary payment, but rather as appropriate spiritual investment and effort.

[i] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an Italian kabbalist whom the author identifies as his teacher. Da Fano was known for synthesizing the kabbalistic systems of Cordovero and Luria and wrote extensively on Jewish mysticism.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Miketz — The Zohar passage is cited as a source encouraging contemplation of one's mortality, which is a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok. This practice of remembering death is presented as a spiritual discipline that leads to proper repentance and preparation. | Cf.

of rewards prepared for the righteous, and there he speaks of the feast of Leviathan,[1] and in section 21 he speaks of the Behemoth in the thousand mountains, and in section 21 of the wild animals of the field.

פרק כ״ח

Chapter 28

ברית ברותה לצדיק המקיים התורה מעוני דהיינו בעודו בגוף העני הלז שהוא מכח החצוני[i] ומיניה וביה יכניעוהו לעבודת יוצרו במצות גשמיות סופו יהיה לקיים התורה מעושר בלבוש מלכות בעולם הנשמות במצות רוחניות ובתפלין של אור[ii] והכתוב צווח ואומר ואהיה שעשועים יום יום[iii] אינו אומר והייתי רק ואהיה בג״ע מקום השעשוע והטיול ואמרו

A covenant is made with the righteous person who fulfills the Torah in poverty, meaning while still within this impoverished body which derives from external forces, and from within itself must subdue those forces to serve its Creator through physical commandments. In the end, such a person will fulfill the Torah in wealth, clothed in royal garments in the World of Souls,[2] through spiritual commandments and with tefillin of light.[3] Scripture proclaims, saying: "And I was daily His delight" [Proverbs 8:30]—it does not say "I was" but rather "I am" in the Garden of Eden, the place of delight

[1]This refers to a concept in Jewish eschatology where the righteous will participate in a feast featuring the primordial Leviathan at the end of days. In kabbalistic literature, this represents the spiritual delights awaiting the righteous in the World to Come.

[2]The concept of 'World of Souls' (olam ha-neshamot) refers to the realm where souls dwell after death but before resurrection. In kabbalistic thought, this is often associated with the Garden of Eden, where souls experience spiritual pleasure and continue their divine service in purely spiritual forms.

[3]The metaphor of 'tefillin of light' (tefillin shel or) represents the transformation of physical ritual objects into their spiritual essence in the afterlife. Just as physical tefillin bind a person to God's service in this world, these spiritual 'tefillin of light' represent the soul's eternal bond with the divine in the World to Come.

Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This Zohar passage is referenced to explain the spiritual economy of commandments, emphasizing that spiritual benefits must be earned through effort and investment, not received freely. This supports the author's broader thesis about the efficacy of proper repentance and ritual action. | Cf. Em Kol Chai — The author references this work by Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (identified as 'the Gaon of Fano') to direct readers to further discussions about rewards for the righteous in the afterlife, including mystical concepts like the feast of Leviathan and the Behemoth, which represent spiritual delights awaiting the righteous. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The reference to 'Tikkunim' points to Tikkunei Zohar, a section of kabbalistic literature that elaborates on the mystical significance of the soul's journey and exile, themes that are central to Ma'avar Yabok's discussion of death and the afterlife.

[i]The text describes the physical body as 'impoverished' and originating from 'external forces' (kochot ha-chitzonim), a kabbalistic term for negative spiritual forces. This reflects the dualistic view common in Jewish mysticism that the body has origins in lower spiritual realms while the soul comes from divine sources.

[ii]The phrase 'tefillin of light' represents a mystical transformation of the physical ritual object (tefillin) into its spiritual counterpart in the afterlife. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that each physical mitzvah has a corresponding spiritual reality in higher worlds.

[iii]This is a quote from Proverbs 8:30, where Wisdom speaks of being God's delight. The author makes an interpretive point about the Hebrew tense, noting that the verse uses the future-continuous form ('I will be/I am') rather than past tense ('I was'), suggesting the ongoing nature of divine delight in the righteous soul.

בשם ספרא דחנוך[i] שכל מצות של הצדיקים בארץ מתעטרים לעומדים לפני המלך ומשתעשע בהם הקב״ה ויורדין ועומדים לפניו בדיוקן אותו צדיק ומשתעשע הקב״ה באותו דיוקן ואח״כ נכתבים בספר זכרון לעמוד לפניו בקיום רב תמיד ועל הכסא דמות כמראה אדם[ii] במראה כולל כל דיוקנין דמלין דחכמתא.[iii]

and spiritual journey.[1] And they said in the name of the Book of Enoch that all the commandments performed by the righteous on earth are crowned before those who stand before the King, and the Holy One, blessed be He, delights in them. They descend and stand before Him in the image of that righteous person,[2] and the Holy One, blessed be He, delights in that image. Afterward, they are inscribed in the Book of Remembrance to stand before Him in great permanence always, "and upon the throne was a likeness as the appearance of a man" [Ezekiel 1:26]—an appearance that encompasses all the images of matters of wisdom.[3]

והמתעסק בתורה שהיא נובלת חכמה של מעלה[iv] כמ״ש בתקון דף ע״ב כי חמה היא נוקבא לגבי שמשא לבנה נוקבא לגבי

One who engages in Torah, which is the fallen fruit of supernal wisdom—as it is written in Tikkun, page 72, that the sun is feminine in relation to the luminary, and the moon is feminine in relation to the

[1]The Hebrew term 'tiyul' (translated here as 'spiritual journey') has special significance in kabbalistic texts, referring to the soul's ability to traverse different spiritual realms and dimensions in the afterlife, an activity that provides sublime pleasure.

[2]The concept of 'diokna' (image) is crucial in kabbalistic understanding of the afterlife. It suggests that the soul maintains a recognizable 'form' even after death, and that this spiritual image continues to interact with divine realms.

[3]This complex phrase suggests that the human form seen on the divine throne encompasses all the spiritual forms created by wisdom and Torah study. In kabbalistic thought, human spiritual achievements become incorporated into the divine presence itself.

[i]The 'Book of Enoch' referenced here is not part of the standard Jewish biblical canon but belongs to pseudepigraphical literature. Its citation demonstrates the breadth of sources the author draws upon for mystical concepts about the afterlife.

[ii]This phrase quotes Ezekiel's vision of the divine throne (Ezekiel 1:26). By connecting this verse to the image of the righteous person, the author suggests a profound elevation of the human soul to the level of divine manifestation after death.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, other sections discussing the World of Souls — This passage expands on a theme found throughout Ma'avar Yabok regarding how actions in this world create corresponding spiritual realities in the World of Souls. The author uses this concept to comfort readers by showing how physical suffering and Torah study in this world transform into spiritual rewards after death. | Cf. Proverbs 8:30 — The author cites this verse about Wisdom being God's delight to suggest that the righteous soul becomes God's eternal delight in the Garden of Eden. The interpretive move is to read the verse's tense as indicating an ongoing present state rather than a past one. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:26 — This reference to Ezekiel's vision of the divine throne is used to suggest that the righteous person's image becomes part of the divine presence itself, incorporating human wisdom into the divine realm. | Cf. Book of Enoch — Though not part of the standard Jewish canon, the reference to the Book of Enoch shows the author's willingness to draw on pseudepigraphical works to support mystical concepts about the afterlife. | Cf. Zoharic concept of diokna (image/likeness) — The passage employs the kabbalistic concept of 'diokna' (spiritual image) from the Zohar, suggesting that the righteous person's spiritual form continues to exist and interact with the divine realm after death.

[iv]This phrase, literally "fallen fruit of supernal wisdom," is a rabbinic concept explaining that Torah as we know it in this world is merely a diminished reflection of the divine wisdom that exists in higher realms. Just as fallen fruit is a small part of what remains on the tree, Torah study in this world gives us only a taste of the complete wisdom we'll experience in the World to Come.

ירח ושם אמרו כי יש מ״ע
פנים למטה מסטרא דישראל
זוטא[i] והוא מטטרו״ן שהוא
מאור הנובל מחכמה של מעלה
דבריאה ודאצילות המתעסק
בה יזכה לעה״ב לאור החכמה
העליונה המחיה את בעליה
כאמרם ז״ל כל המלמד תורה
בעה״ז זוכה ומלמדה לעה״ב
שנאמר ומרוה גם הוא יורה.
ואמרו במדרש רבה פ׳ ס״ד רבי
ברכיה אמר בשם ר׳ יהודה.
אין כל יום שאין הקדוש ברוך
הוא מחדש הלבנה בב״ד של
מעלה. ובש״ר על פסוק לחם
לא אכל ומים לא שתה בעה״ז
אבל לעה״ב הוא אוכל מלחמה
של תורה והוא שותה ממימיה.
ומשה היה ניזון מזיו השכינה.
ואמרו בזהר פ׳ תרומה דלית
גבהו דאורייתא אלא בעלמא
דאתי ווי למאן דאיהו גס רוחא
במילי דאורייתא בעה״ז וכתוב
בר״מ פרשת תרומה וכמה רזין
עילאין אוקימנא במאן דאשתדל
באורייתא דזכי לאתקשרא
באורייתא דלעיל בהאי עלמא
לא שכיך ולא שכיך בעלמא
דאתי ואפי׳ בקבר שפתיה
מרחש׳. אורייתא[ii] כד״א דובב
שפתי ישנים וכה״א דדיה ירווך
בכל עת. והחכם נקרא בעל
תורה דהוא ודאי מאריה דביתא
דהא כל רזין דילה גליאת ליה
ולא כסיאת מיניה כלום והוא
במדרגת בן אחוז בעץ החיים
והעבד הוא אחוז בעץ הדעת
טוב ורע[iii] ואמר בר״מ פ׳
משפטים כי מדרגת נער שנאמר

moon's light—and there they said that there are seventy faces below from the side of Lesser Israel, which is Metatron, who is the light that falls from the supernal wisdom of Beriah and Atzilut. One who engages in it will merit in the World to Come the light of supernal wisdom that gives life to its possessors, as our Sages of blessed memory said: "Whoever teaches Torah in this world merits to teach it in the World to Come," as it is said: "And one who gives drink will also teach" [Proverbs 11:25].

And they said in Midrash Rabbah, chapter 64, Rabbi Berechiah said in the name of Rabbi Judah: "There is no day when the Holy One, blessed be He, does not renew the moon in the heavenly court." And in Shemot Rabbah on the verse "He did not eat bread nor drink water" [Exodus 34:28]—in this world, but in the World to Come, he eats from the bread of Torah and drinks from its waters. And Moses was nourished from the radiance of the Divine Presence.

And they said in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, that the height of Torah is only in the World to Come. Woe to one who is arrogant regarding matters of Torah in this world! And it is written in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Terumah: "And we have established many supernal mysteries concerning one who engages in Torah, who merits to be bound to the Torah above. In this world he does not rest, and in the World to Come he does not rest, and even in the grave his lips murmur Torah," as it is said, "causing the lips of those who sleep to speak" [Song of Songs 7:10], and as it is said, "her breasts will satisfy you at all times" [Proverbs 5:19].

The sage is called a "master of Torah," for he is truly the master of the house, as all its mysteries are revealed to him and nothing is concealed from him. He is at the level of a son who grasps the Tree of Life, while the servant grasps the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. And it says in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Mishpatim, that the level of

[i] The text refers to "seventy faces below from the side of Lesser Israel." The number seventy is significant in Jewish tradition, often representing completeness or totality (seventy nations, seventy languages, etc.). Here, it refers to the multiple layers of interpretation possible within Torah.

[ii] The image of the deceased Torah scholar's lips continuing to murmur Torah in the grave is a powerful rabbinic concept found in several sources. It suggests that the connection between a scholar and Torah transcends death, with their teachings continuing to have influence in this world.

[iii] This presents a hierarchical understanding of Torah mastery. The "son" (ben) who grasps the Tree of Life represents one who understands Torah at its highest level, seeing its unified spiritual essence, while the "servant" (eved) who grasps the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil understands Torah only at the level of permitted and forbidden actions.

במשה כי היה במטטרו״ן קודם
שנדבק בעץ החיים וצד הרע
שבו גרם לו לחטא כי מטה
הראשון היה מעץ הדעת טוב
ורע ובר״מ פ׳ משפטים דף קי״ז
ע״ב פירש בסוד עץ החיים ועץ
הדעת טוב ורע רשע ורע לו.
עוד אמרו בתקון ס״ו דף ק״א
ע״א כי שבירת הלוחות גורם
איבוד בית ראשון ובית שני ושני
חרבנין היו תקון. והכנה לבית
השלישי שמתחלה הוצרך להיות
במדרגת הר ואח״כ במדרגת
שדה ואחר יעלה להיות במדרגת
בית ואז וגו׳ ונלכה אל בית
אלהי יעקב כי זכותו יעמוד
לעד והלוחות שניות היו מבחינת
עץ הדעת טוב ורע שמשם נתנה
תורה באיסור והיתר מימין חיים
ומשמאל מות ולכן א״ר עקיבא
לתלמידיו כשתגיעו לאבני שיש
טהור אל תאמרו מים מים[i] ולא
תהיו שוקלים שיש טהור לאבנים
אחרים שיש בהם חיים ומיתה ולא
עוד אלא כי תסתכנו בעצמכם
שאבני טוב ורע הם בפירוד
ואבני שיש טהור הם ביחוד בלי
פרוד כלל.[ii]

"youth" mentioned regarding Moses was because he was like Metatron before he cleaved to the Tree of Life, and the evil aspect within it caused him to sin, for the first staff was from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. And in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Mishpatim, page 117b, it explains the secret of the Tree of Life and the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil: "the wicked man who fares badly."

They further said in Tikkun 66, page 101a, that the breaking of the tablets caused the destruction of the First and Second Temples, and these two destructions were a rectification and preparation for the Third Temple. For at first it needed to be at the level of a mountain, and afterward at the level of a field, and afterward it would rise to the level of a house, and then "let us go up to the house of the God of Jacob" [Isaiah 2:3], for his merit will stand forever. And the second tablets were from the aspect of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, from which the Torah was given with prohibitions and permissions: life from the right and death from the left. Therefore, Rabbi Akiva said to his disciples: "When you reach the pure marble stones, do not say 'water, water,' and do not equate pure marble with other stones that contain life and death. Moreover, you would endanger yourselves, for the stones of good and evil are in separation, while the stones of pure marble are in unity without any separation at all."

[i] This refers to a famous passage in the Talmud (Hagigah 14b) concerning the mystical journey of four sages who entered "Pardes" (the mystical orchard). Rabbi Akiva warned them not to say "water, water" when they see what appears to be pure marble stones, because these are not physical waters but rather spiritual realities that appear as water. This warning symbolizes the danger of mistaking spiritual unity for duality or separation.

[ii] Cf. Tikkun (Tikkunei Zohar) — The text cites Tikkunei Zohar to establish a metaphysical framework about the hierarchical relationship between celestial bodies, which serves as an analogy for the relationship between different levels of Torah wisdom. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah — This reference establishes the daily renewal of the moon by God in the heavenly court, supporting the idea that divine wisdom is continuously renewed and that Torah study has cosmic significance. | Cf. Shemot Rabbah — This reference contrasts Moses' physical abstinence in this world with spiritual nourishment in the World to Come, establishing that Torah wisdom provides eternal sustenance. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This reference emphasizes that the full comprehension of Torah is only possible in the World to Come and warns against arrogance in Torah study in this world. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Terumah — This reference explains how engaging with Torah creates a connection that transcends death, with the scholar continuing to 'speak' Torah even after death. | Cf. Proverbs 11:25 — This verse is interpreted to mean that one who teaches Torah in this world will continue to teach it in the World to Come. | Cf. Song of Songs 7:10 — This verse about 'causing the lips of those who sleep to speak' is interpreted as referring to the continued teaching of Torah by scholars even after death. | Cf. Proverbs 5:19 — The phrase 'her breasts will satisfy you at all times' is interpreted metaphorically as Torah wisdom continuously nourishing its students even in the afterlife. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Mishpatim — This reference develops the contrast between the Tree of Life and the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil as representing different levels of spiritual understanding, with Moses initially at a lower level

עוד אמרו בפ׳ תרומה דף
קס״ה ע״ב פקודין דאורייתא
גרים לבר נש לאשלמא רוחיה
ונשמתיה בהאי עלמא ובעלמא
דאתי כתיב כי נר מצוה ותורה
אור צריך מעשה המצות בעה״ז
לתקן הנ״ר וצריך עסק התורה
להאיר הנר ונשים מתקנים נר
זה והאנשים בתורה מאירים
להההוא נר שהוא של מצוה
שהנשים נתחייבות בו.[i] עוד
רמז אור הוא למאתים ושבעה
עולמות הגנוזים בצד ימין ומאה
ושלש בצד שמאל[ii] וכבר בארנו
בסוף המעירי שחר שלנו מה
הוא פי׳ עולמות בכל מקום
מס״ה ותקונים ומספר כל
עולמות אלו הם שלש מאות
ועשר ואלה הקב״ה מתקן תמיד
ומאלה מתפשטים כמה אוצרי
חמדה הגנוזים להתעדן בהם
הצדיקים על אלה כתיב להנחיל
אוהבי י״ש. בכל אלה כתיב
עין לא ראתה ואור ימין זה
הוא נקרא אור ראשון ולעולם
הוא עושה תולדות והוא זרוע
בגן ועתה הגן גדל מספיחי

Furthermore, they said in Parashat Terumah, page 165b: "The commandments of the Torah enable a person to perfect their spirit and soul in this world and in the World to Come. It is written, 100R
'For a commandment is a lamp and the Torah is light'[1] (Proverbs 6:23). One needs to perform the commandments in this world to prepare the lamp, and one needs to engage in Torah study to illuminate the lamp. Women prepare this lamp, while men, 105R
through Torah study, illuminate the lamp[2] of the commandment that women are obligated to fulfill."

There is another allusion: "light" refers to the two hundred and seven worlds hidden on the right side, and one hundred and three on the left side.[3] I 110R
have already explained at the end of our Me'irei Shachar[4] what "worlds" means in every instance according to the Zohar and Tikkunim. The total number of these worlds is three hundred and ten. The Holy One, blessed be He, is constantly perfecting 115R
these worlds, and from them extend many treasuries of delight hidden away for the righteous to enjoy. Concerning these it is written, "To bequeath to those who love Me substance (yesh)" (Proverbs 8:21). Regarding all these it is written, "No eye has seen" 120R
(Isaiah 64:3). This light of the right is called the primordial light, and it eternally produces offspring. It is sown in the Garden, and now the Garden grows

[1]This verse from Proverbs 6:23 serves as the foundation for the entire kabbalistic interpretation that follows, where the author develops an elaborate metaphysical system based on the lamp/light imagery.

[2]The original text reflects a gendered division of spiritual labor common in traditional Jewish thought, where women and men have distinct yet complementary religious roles. This is based on women's exemption from certain time-bound commandments and their traditional obligations in three specific mitzvot.

[3]This precise numerical cosmology reflects kabbalistic teaching where the right side is associated with Chesed (loving-kindness) and the left with Gevurah (judgment/strength). The total of 310 worlds likely has significance in gematria (Hebrew numerology).

[4]This appears to be another work by the author of Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena. The title means 'Illuminators of Dawn' and likely refers to a prayer society or collection he compiled.

before ascending. | Cf. Tikkun 66 (Tikkunei Zohar) — This reference connects the breaking of the tablets to the Temple destructions, presenting them as necessary spiritual preparations for the ultimate Third Temple, which represents complete spiritual unity. | Cf. Isaiah 2:3 — This verse about going up to the house of the God of Jacob is cited in connection with the future Third Temple, representing the highest spiritual level.

[i]This passage presents a kabbalistic interpretation of gender roles in Judaism: women prepare the metaphysical 'lamp' through their ritual obligations, while men illuminate this lamp through Torah study, suggesting a complementary cosmic partnership rather than a hierarchy.

[ii]The text uses precise numerical symbolism characteristic of kabbalistic thought: 207 worlds on the right (associated with mercy) and 103 on the left (associated with judgment), totaling 310 worlds. These numbers likely have gematria (numerical) significance in the author's mystical system.

ספיחים ובריש פ׳ פקודי אמר
רע״ג דהוא גנוז ביה קיימין בני
נשא בעלמא דין ובן התורה
נזרעת תמיד בעולם ועושה
תולדות ופירות ומפירות שלה
נזון העולם. וא״כ בכל מצוה
הנפעלת בעולם הזה מתהוה
ממנה שני מיני יחוד האחד בגן
עדן של מעלה והשני בגן עדן
של מטה.[i] וזה סוד השעשוע
למבינים ומכ״ש שתתעלה מאד
הארת המצוה הרוחנית הנעשית
בגן עדן אחר המות ששם הוא
סוד העבודה והשמירה המעולה
ומעלה לשמים שיאה עד אין
קץ שהתעוררות מיושבי הגן
ה״ה נשמותיהם של צדיקים ששם
כבודם יגרום השעשוע שהוא
זווג הספירות וכמו שהמהלך בגן
הוא שעשוע הקב״ה עם שבינתו
כך והתהלכתי בתוככם אטייל
עמכם בגן עדן וגם זה יהיה
זווג הספירות על ידי תקוני
הצדיקים שהיו בעוה״ז ומי שהיה
בן יעבד להקב״ה בחייו יזכה
להיות עומד ומשמש כבן או
כעבד במותו ויהיה לו מהלכים
בעולמות הנזכרות ובזה טוב
יום המות מיום הולדו. וכתב
הגאון מורי מפאנו[ii] בפ״ק מחלק
ב׳ מחקור דין שלו כי ביום
החטא נולד המבטל שלפתח
חטאת רובץ וביום המות יתבטל
המבטל וטוביות המות הוא כי

from the aftergrowths of aftergrowths.[1] At the beginning of Parashat Pekudei, it says that this hidden light sustains humanity in this world. Similarly, the Torah is constantly being sown in the world, producing offspring and fruits, and from its fruits the world is nourished.

Therefore, with each commandment performed in this world, two types of unification are generated: one in the supernal Garden of Eden, and the second in the lower Garden of Eden. This is the secret of delight for those who understand. How much more so will the illumination of the spiritual commandment performed in the Garden of Eden after death be elevated, for there lies the secret of superior service and protection, ascending to the heavens immeasurably. For the stirring from the Garden's inhabitants—these are the souls of the righteous—whose honor there causes the delight that is the union of the sefirot. Just as one who walks in the Garden is the delight of the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence, so too "I will walk among you" (Leviticus 26:12) means "I will stroll with you in the Garden of Eden." This too will be a union of the sefirot through the rectifications of the righteous who existed in this world.

One who was a son serving the Holy One, blessed be He, during their lifetime will merit to stand and serve as a son or as a servant after death, and will have pathways in the worlds mentioned. In this way, the day of death is better than the day of birth.[2] My teacher, the Gaon of Fano,[3] wrote in the first chapter of the second part of his Chikor Din that on the day of sin, the negator was born, as it is written, "sin crouches at the door" (Genesis 4:7), and on the day

[1] The Hebrew term 'ספיחי ספיחים' (sfikhei sfikhim) literally refers to plants that grow spontaneously from seeds that fell during the previous harvest, and then from those secondary plants. Here it's used metaphorically to describe how divine light continues to generate spiritual sustenance through multiple generations of emanation.

[2] This phrase echoes Ecclesiastes 7:1 ('the day of death is better than the day of one's birth'). The author gives this biblical wisdom a kabbalistic interpretation, explaining that death is superior because it transforms and purifies the evil inclination.

[3] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an important Italian kabbalist who synthesized the teachings of Moses Cordovero and Isaac Luria. Aaron Berechia of Modena identifies him as his teacher, establishing his intellectual lineage.

[i] The author presents a sophisticated kabbalistic understanding of mitzvot (commandments) where each physical action in this world generates two distinct spiritual unifications in different celestial realms—a concept that shows how human religious acts have cosmic significance.

[ii] The author refers to Rabbi Menachem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620) as 'my teacher,' indicating his direct intellectual lineage within Italian Kabbalah. Da Fano was a prominent kabbalist who synthesized the teachings of Moses Cordovero and Isaac Luria.

יטהר היצר הרע עצמו[i] וכמו שהרע מכלה את עצמו כנגדו הטוב מתרבה מיניה וביה כי יסודו מהעפר הקדוש העושה תולדות ופירות כדאמרי׳ על מעשה הצדיקים שיש להם קרן ופירות:[ii]

of death, the negator will be nullified. The goodness of death is that the evil inclination itself becomes purified. Just as evil consumes itself, so does good increase from within itself, for its foundation is from the holy earth that produces offspring and fruits, as they said regarding the deeds of the righteous, that they have both principal and fruits.[1]

פרק כ״ט

Chapter 29

ולא זו בלבד שמור להם לצדיקים אלא מצותיהם יגדילו כ״כ למעלה כח הקדושה שאפילו גהינם יטהר ויתוסף על גבולי הגן עדן[iii] וזה לפי ששכר מצות

Not only is this reward preserved for the righteous, but their commandments will so greatly increase the power of holiness above that even Gehenna will be purified and added to the boundaries of the Garden of Eden.[A] This is because "there is no reward

[A] Or: "even Gehenna will be purified and its territory will be incorporated into the boundaries of the Garden of Eden" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the spatial transformation implied in the original text, where Gehenna's territory is not merely added to Eden

[1] The concepts of 'principal' (keren) and 'fruits' (peirot) come from rabbinic teachings about rewards for good deeds. The 'principal' is preserved for the World to Come, while the 'fruits' can be enjoyed in this world (Mishnah Peah 1:1). The author gives this traditional concept a kabbalistic interpretation.

[i] The text presents an unusual positive theology of death, suggesting that death purifies even the evil inclination itself, transforming what is typically viewed as negative into something ultimately beneficial in the divine cosmic plan.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This passage quotes directly from the Zohar Terumah to establish the relationship between Torah study, commandment observance, and their effects on the soul in both worlds. The Zohar text forms the foundation for the author's subsequent mystical interpretation about the spiritual mechanics of mitzvot. | Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — This biblical verse serves as the basis for the mystical exegesis connecting commandments to lamps/candles and Torah study to light, establishing a metaphorical framework that the author then expands into a comprehensive kabbalistic system. | Cf. Proverbs 8:21 — This reference supports the author's teaching about divine rewards stored for the righteous, connecting material from Proverbs to the kabbalistic concept of hidden treasuries of delight in the supernal worlds. | Cf. Isaiah 64:3 — This biblical reference emphasizes the transcendent nature of the divine rewards stored for the righteous, reinforcing that these spiritual treasuries exist beyond ordinary human perception. | Cf. Leviticus 26:12 — The author reinterprets this biblical verse, originally about God's presence among the Israelites, as a mystical reference to divine strolling in the Garden of Eden with the souls of the righteous, transforming a covenant promise into a description of posthumous spiritual intimacy. | Cf. Genesis 4:7 — This verse is used to describe the origin of the evil inclination ('the negator') that emerged at the time of sin, establishing a theological framework where death serves the positive function of nullifying this negative force. | Cf. Zohar Parashat Pekudei — The author references the Zohar's teaching that the primordial light sustains humanity, creating a parallel between this light and Torah as cosmic sustaining forces that nourish the world. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author references his own work 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), showing the interconnection between his writings and suggesting that this current text builds upon concepts previously established there regarding the mystical meaning of 'worlds.' | Cf. Chikor Din by Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano — The author cites his teacher's work to support his mystical interpretation of death as a positive event that purifies the evil inclination, showing how his teachings build upon established kabbalistic traditions.

[iii] This remarkable concept suggests that at the end of days, even Gehenna (Hell) will be purified and incorporated into the boundaries of Paradise, representing a complete cosmic transformation where even the realm of punishment becomes part of the divine good.

בהאי עלמא ליכא וחסידה שהיא השכינה בשמים ידעה מועדיה[i] וחושבת מחשבות להכין לעת קץ. וכל המצות והמעשים טובים בעושים ישראל היא אוצרת אותם בגן עדן וכל חדושי תורה שמחדשים ישראל עתידים הם לאומרם לעוה״ב בתוספת בינה כנראה באדרת נשא כי אחר שסיימו רבי שמעון בן יוחאי וחביריו י״ג תקוני אריך. קודם התחלתם בתשעה תקוני זעיר בישר רשב״י לשבעה עיני ה׳ שנשארו מהעשר שהיו כי קב״ה גמר דין דלעלמא דאתי יאמרו הם זמנא אחרא כל אינון מלין קדישין ובין דא לדא הם כמוסים בגן עד כי יבא עת שלמותן ומצרף גם כן כל מחשבות טובות של ישראל למעשה ואפי׳ הקרבנות נעשים למעלה כאלו ב״ה היה קיים כי מיכאל מקריב למעלה עבורנו כבשים של אש[ii] וזהו ואישי ישראל ותפלתם בדדרש הגאון מורי מפאנו על פסוק שמחנו כימות עניתנו בריש עשרה מאמרות שלו. והנה תמיד בכל יום מתרבים האורות למעלה בחדרי גן עדן מלבד הנשמות הקדושות והישיבות אשר מתוספת שם מדי יום ביום ולהיות כי אין שפע יורד למטה שהכל משומר לעת קץ לכן למטה בכל יום קללתו מרובה מחבירו.[iii] ואמרי׳ בירושלמי

for commandments in this world," and the stork, which represents the Divine Presence, "knows her appointed times in the heavens" and devises plans to prepare for the end of days. All the commandments and good deeds that Israel performs, She stores in the Garden of Eden, and all the Torah insights that Israel creates, they will eventually recite them in the World to Come with additional understanding, as seen in the Idra of Naso. For after Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his companions completed the thirteen rectifications of Arich, before beginning the nine rectifications of Zeir, Rabbi Shimon announced to the "seven eyes of the Lord" that remained from the original ten that the Holy One, blessed be He, decreed that in the World to Come, they would explain all these holy matters[A] another time. And between this time and that, they remain hidden in the Garden until the time of their completion.

He also combines all the good thoughts of Israel into deeds, and even the sacrifices are performed above as if the Temple still existed, for Michael offers on our behalf lambs of fire above. This is the meaning of "the fire-offerings of Israel and their prayer," as my teacher, the Gaon of Fano, interpreted regarding the verse "Gladden us according to the days You afflicted us" at the beginning of his Ten Discourses. Indeed, every day the lights increase above in the chambers of the Garden of Eden, besides the holy souls and academies that are added there daily. And since no divine flow descends below, as everything is preserved for the end of days, therefore below, each day's curse exceeds that of the previous day.

As stated in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah, Chapter 7: "The aftergrowths we ate in our youth were better than the peaches we ate in our

10R 15R 20R 25R 30R 35R 40R

but actually becomes part of it. This better captures the cosmic reconfiguration described in the eschatological vision.

[A] Or: "all those holy words" — The Aramaic 'מלין' specifically refers to words or utterances rather than matters or topics. This alternate translation better preserves the emphasis on the actual teachings and discourses that will be explained in the World to Come, rather than just the concepts.

[i] The author interprets the stork (חסידה) from Jeremiah 8:7 as representing the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), using wordplay since חסידה also shares a root with חסד (kindness). This metaphor suggests that the Divine Presence knows the proper timing for redemption and is actively preparing for it.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the archangel Michael continues to perform celestial sacrifices on Israel's behalf even after the destruction of the Temple, suggesting that earthly ritual practices have cosmic analogues that continue in the spiritual realms.

[iii] This references the Talmudic concept that the world continuously degenerates spiritually in the

דפאה פ״ז יפין ספיחות שאכלנו
בילדותינו מפרסקין שאכלנו
בזקנותינו דביומוי אשתני עלמא
ועל דרך זה אמרי׳ במסכת גיטין
45 אך למעלה בכל יום ברכתו
מרובה. וזהו טעם דבעקבות
משיחא חוצפא יסגי וכי יבא
כנהר צר רוח ה׳ ינוססה בו
כי אז הגן והעדן יהיה מלא על
50 כל גדותיו משובע וברכת ה׳
והמולות המולות שרפי קדש
נבראים ונוצרים ונעשים ממעשה
התחתונים מיום חרבן בית ראשון
עד יום הגאולה ולעת קץ ברגע
55 יפתחו שערי הגן ואחריו שערי
העדן תחתון ועליון ומרוב
הכחות קדושות והארות עליונות
שיצאו כלם יחד יתבסם ויטהר
העולם ורוח הטומאה יעבור
60 מן הארץ וגר זאב עם כבש וגו׳
ושעשע יונק שהוא מטטרון על
חור פתן[i] על נוקבא דתהומא
רבה ויבולע סם מן סמאל וכן
מכל כחותיו ואז יתקדש גם כן
65 חללה של גהינם המכוונת נגד
פתחי גן עדן והיו כל זדים וכל
עושי רשעה קש ולהט אותם
היום הבא ברוך אשר לו נתכנו
עלילות. ובזה נבין אמרם שלשה
70 באים בהיסח הדעת.[ii] האחד
משיח וגם עקרב[iii]

old age," for in his days the world changed. And in this vein, we say in Tractate Gittin that above, each day's blessing exceeds the previous. This explains why in the footsteps of the Messiah, insolence will increase, but "when distress comes like a river, 45R
the spirit of the Lord will raise a standard against it," for then the Garden and Eden will be filled to overflowing with divine abundance and blessing. Multitudes upon multitudes of holy seraphim are created, formed, and made[A] from the deeds of those 50R
below, from the day of the destruction of the First Temple until the day of redemption. At the end of days, in an instant, the gates of the Garden will open, followed by the gates of lower and upper Eden. Due to the abundance of holy powers and 55R
supernal illuminations that will all emerge together, the world will become fragrant and purified, and the spirit of impurity will pass from the earth, and "the wolf will dwell with the lamb," etc. The suckling child, who is Metatron, will play over the hole of 60R
the asp, over the opening of the great abyss, and poison will be swallowed from Samael and from all his forces. Then even the void of Gehenna, which is aligned opposite the entrances to the Garden of Eden, will be sanctified, and all the wicked and 65R
evildoers will be like stubble, and the coming day will consume them—blessed is He to whom all actions are reckoned.

Through this we can understand their statement that three things come when one's mind is diverted: 70R
one is the Messiah, and also the scorpion [that stings

[A] Or: "Tumultuous multitudes of holy seraphim are being created, formed, and fashioned" — The Hebrew phrase 'המולות המולות' has a connotation of noise and commotion beyond just quantity, suggesting a dynamic, vibrant process of angelic creation. The alternate translation attempts to capture this auditory and energetic quality of the multitudes being described.

pre-messianic era. The author presents the paradox that while the earthly realm experiences increasing darkness, the heavenly realms simultaneously accumulate increasing light.

[i] The author interprets Isaiah's messianic prophecy (11:8) "A suckling child shall play over the hole of the asp" in kabbalistic terms, identifying the child with the angel Metatron who will neutralize the cosmic forces of evil (represented by Samael) at the time of redemption.

[ii] This is a reference to the Talmudic statement (Sanhedrin 97a) that three things come unexpectedly: the Messiah, a found object, and a scorpion. The author begins to explain this concept but the passage is cut off.

[iii] Cf. Idra of Naso — The text references the Idra of Naso (a section of the Zohar containing Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's mystical teachings), specifically regarding the thirteen rectifications of Arich and nine rectifications of Zeir, which are kabbalistic configurations of divine attributes. This reference establishes that Torah insights developed in this world will be more fully understood in the World to Come. | Cf. Gaon of Fano — The author cites Rabbi Menachem Azariah of Fano (referred to as 'my teacher, the Gaon of Fano'), demonstrating both intellectual lineage and the source for the interpretation about sacrifices being offered by the angel Michael in the absence

when one's attention is elsewhere].

שהוא החמא העוקץ בא
משום שהסיח דעתו מן
הקדושה.[i] ומציאה כפשטה.[ii] ועיין
בפ׳ כי תשא דף קפ״ח ופ״ט וצ׳ 75R
ושם משל נאה.[iii] הנה כי
הצדיקים מקיימים בגן עדן
עליון ותחתון מצות ומעשים
טובים ברוחניות יותר גדול וזה 80R
מעין חותם המצות דוקא שעסקו
בהם בעולם הזה:[iv] וממה שבא
בהקדמת תקוני הזהר נראה

The sin that stings comes because one has turned his mind away from holiness.[A] And a "finding" is meant literally.[1] See in Parashat Ki Tisa pages 188, 189, and 190, where there is a beautiful parable.[B] Indeed, the righteous fulfill commandments and good deeds in the upper and lower Garden of Eden with even greater spirituality, and this resembles the seal of specifically those commandments they engaged with in this world.[C]

From what appears in the introduction to Tikkunei Zohar, it seems that a person has many

[A] Or: "The stinging sin [like a scorpion] comes because one has diverted his attention from holiness" — The term 'עוקץ' (stinging) has a connotation of a scorpion's sting in rabbinic literature, creating a metaphor for sin as a scorpion that stings when one's guard is down. This adds a layer of imagery that might better convey the original metaphor.

[B] Or: "See in the Zohar on Parashat Ki Tisa, folios 188, 189, and 190, where there is an elegant parable" — The reference is clearly to the Zohar on Parashat Ki Tisa, not the biblical passage itself. Specifying 'Zohar' and using 'folios' instead of 'pages' more accurately reflects the nature of the reference in this mystical text.

[C] Or: "this is like the spiritual imprint of precisely those commandments they occupied themselves with in this world" — The concept of 'חותם' (seal) in Kabbalistic literature often refers to a spiritual imprint or impression that leaves its mark in higher worlds. This translation better conveys the mystical concept that one's actions in this world create corresponding spiritual realities in the next.

[1] The author is explaining that while the 'scorpion' in the triad is metaphorical (representing sin), the 'finding' (metziah) should be understood in its plain sense as a lost object that one finds unexpectedly.

of the Temple. This establishes the concept that earthly religious practices have cosmic impact even without the physical Temple. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Pe'ah — The citation about aftergrowths in youth versus peaches in old age illustrates the decline of the material world over time, contrasting with the spiritual realm where illumination increases daily. This supports the author's theological framework that divine abundance accumulates in supernal realms while being withheld from the earthly realm until the messianic era. | Cf. wolf will dwell with the lamb — This biblical reference to messianic peace is reinterpreted in kabbalistic terms to describe the transformation and purification of all spiritual realms, including even Gehenna (Hell), suggesting that the ultimate redemption will reconcile all opposing forces in creation. | Cf. when distress comes like a river, the spirit of the Lord will raise a standard against it — This prophetic verse is used to explain the paradox of increasing spiritual darkness before messianic redemption, suggesting that the crescendo of negative forces will be met with a proportional divine response when the accumulated spiritual merits are finally released into the world.

[i] This statement follows the author's mention of three things that come unexpectedly: the Messiah, the scorpion (or sin), and a lost object. Here, he elaborates that sin, metaphorically likened to a scorpion's sting, attacks when one's attention has been diverted from holiness.

[ii] The author is explaining the third item that comes unexpectedly—a found object (metzia)—stating that this should be understood literally, unlike the metaphorical interpretation he provides for sin/scorpion.

[iii] The author refers to a parable in the Zohar's commentary on Exodus (Ki Tisa) that illustrates how distraction from holiness creates vulnerability to sin. This cross-reference is characteristic of kabbalistic literature, which often builds arguments through interwoven textual references.

[iv] This expresses the kabbalistic concept that one's actions in this world create corresponding spiritual realities in the next. The mitzvot performed in this world leave a spiritual 'seal' or 'imprint' that determines the nature of one's spiritual activities in Gan Eden after death.

כי הרבה מסייעים יש לאדם
המגלים לו רזי תורה וכל שכן
לעוה״ב. ראשונה יש אליהו עוד
נשמות של מתיבתאן עילאין.
המלאכים. שמות הקדושים
הויות וכנוים. ועשר ספירות
והארת הנשמות למעלה הוא מן
הכסא ופורחין מצדיק חי עלמין
ומאירין למלכות. ובעלי הקבלה
פורחין לעולם אחר השכינה
ועליהם נאמר לא תקח האם על
הבנים[i] ועוסקי בתורה לשמה
הם בגדר זה וכן מניחי תפלין
ומיחדי קריאת שמע ושומרי אות
ברית קדש ומקיימי לולב באגדו
וסוכה הם פורחים אחר השכינה.
ובתקון י״ח אמר רבי שמעון בן
יוחאי כי העוסק בתורת ה׳ כל
הבריות מסייעים אותו[ii] כמה
דאוקמוה כל העולם כלו לא
נברא אלא לצוות לזה ואפילו
שרפים וחיות ואופנים לא נבראו
אלא לסייעו וכל העוסק בטל
תורה לשמה טל תורה מחייהו
ובתקון ס״ט דף קי״א אמר כי
נצוץ נשמת מרע״ה מתפשט בכל
צדיק וחכם שעוסק בתורה. וזהו
משה שפיר קאמרת דאיתמר

helpers who reveal to him the secrets of Torah, and all the more so in the World to Come. First, there is Elijah, then the souls from the heavenly academies,[1] the angels, the holy Names—the Tetragrammaton and divine epithets[2]—and the ten sefirot. The illumination of souls above comes from the Throne, and they fly from "the Righteous One, Life of the Worlds" and illuminate Malkhut (Kingdom).[A] The masters of Kabbalah always fly after the Divine Presence, and concerning them it is said, "You shall not take the mother bird with the young."[3] Those who engage in Torah study for its own sake are in this category, as are those who don tefillin, unify through the recitation of the Shema, guard the sign of the holy covenant, and fulfill the commandments of the lulav bundle and sukkah—they all fly after the Divine Presence.

In the 18th Tikkun, Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai said that when one engages in God's Torah, all creatures assist him, as they established: "The entire world was created only to accompany this person." Even the seraphim, holy beasts, and wheel angels were created only to assist him. Anyone who engages in the dew of Torah for its own sake is given life by the dew of Torah.[4] And in Tikkun 69, page 111, he said that a spark of Moses our Teacher's soul extends into every righteous person and sage who engages in Torah.[5] This is the meaning of "Moses, you have

[A] Or: "and they emanate from Yesod (the Righteous One, Life of the Worlds) and illuminate Malkhut (Kingdom)" — In Kabbalistic terminology, 'צדיק חי עלמין' specifically refers to the sefirah of Yesod. Adding this technical term provides greater precision for readers familiar with Kabbalah and clarifies the mystical cosmology being described, where divine light flows from Yesod to Malkhut.

[1] The term 'מתיבתאן עילאין' refers to celestial academies where the souls of departed sages continue to study Torah. This concept of heavenly yeshivot is common in rabbinic and mystical literature.
[2] The Hebrew 'הויות וכנוים' refers to the four-letter divine name (YHVH) and other divine titles or descriptive names used for God in Jewish tradition.
[3] The author creatively reinterprets the biblical commandment from Deuteronomy 22:6-7 about sending away a mother bird before taking her young. In this mystical reading, pursuing the Divine Presence must be done with proper reverence and spiritual approach.
[4] This plays on the dual meaning of 'טל' (tal/dew), which can refer both to the dew of resurrection in Jewish tradition and to the life-giving qualities of Torah study. The phrase suggests that proper Torah study itself provides spiritual vitality.
[5] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'nitzotzot neshamah' (soul sparks), where the souls of

[i] The author creatively reinterprets the biblical commandment about sending away a mother bird before taking her young (Deuteronomy 22:6-7). In this mystical reading, those who pursue the Divine Presence (the 'mother bird') must do so with proper reverence and spiritual approach.
[ii] Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai was the traditional author of the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism. The teaching cited here from Tikkun 18 of Tikkunei Zohar emphasizes the cosmic support system available to those engaged in Torah study.

בגמרא[i] ואמרו עוד כי העוסק בתלמוד לעתיד לבא ילך עם בעלי תלמוד אם במשנה ילך עם בעלי משנה וכן במקרא ואגדה. וירא אלהים יעשה לו מהלכים בין כל העומדים האלה. ובתבו שטוב להתענות קודם סיום המסכתא.[ii] [iii]

spoken well," as mentioned in the Talmud. They further said that one who studies Talmud will, in the future, walk with masters of Talmud; if one studies Mishnah, they will walk with masters of Mishnah; and likewise with Scripture and Aggadah. One who fears God will be granted pathways among all these standing ones. And they wrote that it is good to fast before completing a tractate.[1]

וברבה פ׳ כי תצא אמר ר׳ שמעון בן לקיש כל מי שנכנס לבתי כנסיות ולבתי מדרשות בעוה״ז זוכה ליכנס שם לעתיד לבא שנאמר אשרי יושבי ביתך עוד יהללוך סלה. ויהללוך לעתיד משמע ר״א אמר ר׳ יודן כל מי ששומע בקול תורה בעוה״ז זוכה לשמוע אותו קול לעוה״ב וכו׳. וכל מה שעוסקים המלאכים וצדיקים בג״ע אינו רק בכ״ד ספרים ובתורה שבע״פ. ומבעי ליה לאדם להסתיר מעשיו הטובים מבני אדם שבזה שכרו יהיה נסתר מבעלי הדין שהקב״ה חופה עליו. כדאמרי׳ בירושלמי

And in Rabbah, Parashat Ki Teitzei, Rabbi Shimon ben Lakish said: "Anyone who enters synagogues and houses of study in this world merits to enter them in the future world, as it is said, 'Happy are those who dwell in Your house; they will praise You forever' (Psalms 84:5). 'They will praise You' implies in the future." Rabbi Eleazar said in the name of Rabbi Yudan: "Anyone who listens to the voice of Torah in this world merits to hear that voice in the World to Come," and so forth. And all that the angels and righteous ones engage with in the Garden of Eden[2] is only the twenty-four books [of the Bible] and the Oral Torah.

A person should conceal his good deeds from people, for by doing so, his reward will remain hidden from the forces of judgment, as the Holy One, blessed

great figures contain multitudes of sparks that become distributed among later generations. Here, every true Torah scholar is said to contain an element of Moses's soul.

[1] This refers to the practice of fasting before a siyum (completion ceremony) of a Talmudic tractate, treating this intellectual achievement as a spiritual occasion worthy of ascetic preparation.

[2] Throughout the text, the author uses 'Garden of Eden' (Gan Eden) as a metaphor for both the afterlife and the elevated spiritual state achieved through Torah study, particularly at midnight.

[i] The phrase 'Moses, you have spoken well' appears in several Talmudic passages when a sage makes a particularly insightful interpretation. The author suggests this is because every Torah scholar who speaks wisdom contains a spark of Moses' soul.

[ii] This refers to the practice of fasting before completing the study of a Talmudic tractate, which was considered a spiritually significant occasion worthy of special preparation.

[iii] Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The passage explicitly cites the Tikkunei Zohar, specifically mentioning Tikkun 18 and Tikkun 69, to establish the concept that mystical study is supported by various spiritual entities, especially in the afterlife. The author uses these references to establish authoritative support for the concept of expanded mystical understanding in the World to Come. | Cf. Zohar on Parashat Ki Tisa — The text references specific folios in the Zohar on Parashat Ki Tisa regarding a parable about distraction from holiness. This reference supports the opening statement about sin coming from turning away from holiness, connecting the theoretical concept to a narrative illustration in the Zohar. | Cf. Deuteronomy 22:6-7 — The phrase 'לא תקח האם על הבנים' (do not take the mother with the young) alludes to Deuteronomy 22:6-7. In this context, it's being used metaphorically—Kabbalists who pursue the Divine Presence (the mother bird) must maintain proper spiritual distance and reverence, similar to the biblical commandment of sending away the mother bird before taking the young. | Cf. Talmudic concept of 'Moses, you have spoken well' — The phrase 'משה שפיר קאמרת' (Moses, you have spoken well) appears in several Talmudic passages when a sage makes a particularly insightful interpretation. Here it's used to suggest that when any Torah scholar speaks wisely, it's because they contain a spark of Moses' soul, explaining why this expression appears throughout the Talmud.

דמועד קטן על ההיא איתתא
דאיענשא משום דהות מפרסמא
עצמה בימי תעניתה וזה א׳
ממעלות התפלין שנקראי׳ כנפי
יונה שמסתירים הנשמה מבעלי
הדין כיונה המגינה בכנפיה. על
כן אשרי אדם אשר לו שיח ושיג
תמיד בסדרי זרעים וקדשים
וטהרות וכן בשאר המצות שלא
יוכל לקיימן במעשה יהגה בהם
ועקימת פיו יחשב לו למעשה
אחר מיתתו ובזה יזכה לקיים
כל התורה כלה בעולם הנשמות
וזהו שכר מצוה מצוה וכבר ידוע
שסגולות המשניות הם להכניע
היצר שהם בעולם דמטטרו״ן עץ
הדעת טוב ורע ויכוין להרוג
היצר בגרסתו כדאמרי׳ בדוד
דקטליה בגרסתיה ועל כן אמר
ולבי חלל בקרבי. ויועיל
שנונם ג״כ לטהרת המחשבות
ובזרעים מרבה זרע הקדוש לגן
עליון ובטהרות מטהר עצמו
ומחשבותיו ובקדשים מקדש
עצמו ומקדש עליון וכן כל סדר
ומסכתא יש להם סגולה בפני
עצמה כאשר בארנו בסוף מעירי
שחר שלנו. ואחזה אנכי אשית
לבי כי טוב לכל משכיל לתקון
נפשו לקרא פעם אחת בכל שנה
ספר הסמ״ג מלבד כי כל הוגה
בו יחכם ויידע להדורי סברא
בפלפולי התוספות וגאוני עולם.
עוד סגולה נפלאה להרוג היצר
ולהכניעו הוא לקום בחצות
לילה לעסוק בתורה כי מלבד
מעלות רבות שזוכה אליהם
כמו שבא מזה למעלה ויבא ג״כ
לפנינו בעה״י הוא הורג היצר
ומכניעו וזה רמזו רז״ל באמרם
הבא להרגך השכם להרגו כלומר
בא השטן להרגך אין לך במה

be He, covers over him. As we find in the Jerusalem Talmud of Moed Katan regarding a certain woman who was punished because she publicized herself during her fast days. This is one of the virtues of tefillin, which are called "wings of a dove," as they conceal the soul from the forces of judgment, like a dove that protects with its wings.

Therefore, fortunate is the person who constantly discusses the orders of Zeraim [Seeds], Kodashim [Holy Things], and Taharot [Purities], as well as other commandments he cannot fulfill practically. He should meditate upon them, and the movement of his lips will be considered as if he performed them after his death. Through this, he will merit to fulfill the entire Torah in the world of souls, and this is the meaning of "the reward of a commandment is a commandment." It is well known that the special qualities of the Mishnayot are to subdue the evil inclination,[1] as they exist in the world of Metatron, the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. One should intend to kill the evil inclination through study, as they said regarding David, who killed it through his study, and thus he said, "My heart is hollow within me" (Psalms 109:22).

Diligent study also purifies one's thoughts. Through [studying the order of] Zeraim, one increases holy seed for the supernal garden; through Taharot, one purifies oneself and one's thoughts; and through Kodashim, one sanctifies oneself and the supernal realm. Similarly, each order and tractate has its own special quality, as we explained at the end of our "Me'irei Shachar" [Illuminators of Dawn].

I perceive and set my heart to realize that it is good for every thoughtful person seeking to perfect his soul to read the Sefer HaMitzvot HaGadol [SeMaG] once each year. Besides the fact that anyone who studies it will become wise and know how to reason in the dialectics of the Tosafists and the great scholars, there is another wonderful quality for killing and subduing the evil inclination: rising at midnight to engage in Torah study.[2] Beyond the many virtues one attains through this, as mentioned above and as

[1] The author presents a mystical understanding of Mishnah study where each order creates specific spiritual effects: Zeraim (agricultural laws) produces 'spiritual seeds,' Taharot (purity laws) creates spiritual purification, and Kodashim (sacrificial laws) generates sanctification in higher realms.

[2] Midnight Torah study (Tikkun Chatzot) is considered especially potent in Kabbalistic tradition because it occurs during the time when divine judgment is balanced with mercy. This practice became particularly emphasized in Kabbalistic circles following the teachings of Isaac Luria in the 16th century.

שתהרגהו אלא בהשכמה וזהו
השכם ובזה אתה הורגו והטעם
כי אז הוא היחוד מדת לילה
ביום והיחוד הוא הריגת ס״מ
ואם הוא ישן הוא נהרג כי השליט
עליו המות לשינה כי היא אחד
משישים במיתה. וזהו שאמר
ההוא ספדנא נשים ימים כלילות
על מי שמשים לילות כימים
דהיינו היחוד שהיה מיחד היום
עם הלילה. א״כ אשריו ואשרי
חלקו ממי שהוא מתגבר כארי
להשתעשע עם הקדושה בג״ע
מחצות ואילך: [i]

will be discussed later with God's help, it kills and subdues the evil inclination. This is what our Sages hinted at when they said, "If someone comes to kill you, rise early to kill him"—meaning, when Satan comes to kill you, you have no means to kill him except by rising early, and this is the meaning of "rise early." Through this, you kill him. The reason is that this is the time of unification between the attribute of night and day, and this unification is the killing of Samael.[1] If one is sleeping, he is being killed, for he has allowed death to rule over him through sleep, which is one-sixtieth of death.[2] This is what the eulogizer meant when he said, "Let us make days as nights for one who made nights as days"—meaning the unification that unified day with night.[3] Therefore, fortunate is he and fortunate is his portion, one who strengthens himself like a lion to delight with holiness in the Garden of Eden from midnight onward.

פרק ל׳

Chapter 30

אם כן גדול כחן של עושי מצוה
בעוה״ב למה ינום אדם הנלבב
ויישן אם הוא כשכיר יקוה פעלו
להרבות כבוד עליון ע״כ תמיד

Therefore, since the power of those who perform commandments in the World to Come is so great, why should a thoughtful person slumber and sleep? If one is like a laborer who anticipates his wages[4] to

[1] Samael (often abbreviated as S"M in kabbalistic texts) is a name for the angel of death or Satan. The concept that Torah study 'kills' this entity reflects the kabbalistic understanding that spiritual disciplines neutralize negative spiritual forces.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic concept (Berakhot 57b) that sleep is a minor form of death, considered one-sixtieth of actual death. The author uses this to suggest that sleeping through the spiritually potent midnight hour is a form of spiritual surrender to death forces.

[3] In Kabbalistic thought, 'unification' (yichud) refers to the mystical joining of opposing cosmic forces or divine attributes. Here, midnight Torah study creates a unification between day (representing mercy/masculine) and night (representing judgment/feminine) forces, which has cosmic repercussions.

[4] The metaphor of a laborer (שכיר) waiting for wages appears in biblical texts like Leviticus 19:13 and Job 7:2. Here it's repurposed to suggest that humans should view their religious obligations

[i] Cf. Psalms 84:5 — This verse is used as proof that those who attend synagogues and study houses in this world will merit to enter them in the World to Come, with particular emphasis on the word 'od' (yet/still/again) suggesting future praise. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Moed Katan — This reference is brought as a cautionary tale about a woman who was punished for publicizing her fasting, teaching that good deeds should be done privately. | Cf. Psalms 109:22 — The verse is interpreted to mean that David had killed his evil inclination through Torah study, leaving his heart 'hollow' or empty of evil desires. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — This appears to be another work by the same author (Aaron Berechia of Modena) where he previously elaborated on the special qualities of each Mishnaic order and tractate. | Cf. Sefer HaMitzvot HaGadol (SeMaG) — The author recommends annual study of this comprehensive legal code by Rabbi Moses of Coucy (13th century) as beneficial for spiritual development and intellectual growth. | Cf. Talmudic dictum 'If someone comes to kill you, rise early to kill him' — This well-known Talmudic principle about self-defense is reinterpreted mystically to refer to rising early (particularly at midnight) to study Torah as a means of defeating the evil inclination (Satan).

לא יחשה מתורה ותעודה ויהיה
רץ למצוה קלה כבחמורה כדי
שיעשה לו הכנה לקיים תורה
ומצות בסוד רוחניותם שבגן
עליון ותחתון. ואם ירצה לזכות
לפתורא דדהבא מסמכת מזכות
ג׳ אבות[i] הגומלים חסדים טובים
ומירכין עילאין ומסיומא דגופא
יסדר שולחנו בעוה״ז לפני ה׳
ולפני הפנים עליונים שלכן
אמרו כי היה נקרא לחם הפנים
להיותו שואב מהפנים עליונים.
וצריך על כל שלחן דברי תורה
וחלק לעניים דכתיב ונפש נענה
תשביע ואח״כ אז תתענג על ה׳
מכל אינון עידונין דאתמשכאן
לההוא כבוד עליון ואמרי׳ בפ׳
תרומה דף קנ״ו ע״ב כי שלחן יש
לצדיקים בעולם ההוא שהמזון
וספוק של עידון שאוכלים באותו
עולם הוא כמו מה שאוכלים
מלאכים עליונים[ii] ומזה אכלו
ישראל במדבר והוא סוד הטל
דנגיד ונמשך מסוד עוה״ב ומשם

increase the glory of the Most High, then one should never be silent from Torah and testimony, and should run to perform a minor commandment as eagerly as a major one,[1] in order to prepare oneself to fulfill Torah and commandments in their spiritual essence that exists in the upper and lower Garden of Eden. And if one wishes to merit a golden table[A] supported by the merit of the three Patriarchs[2] who bestow good kindnesses, and by the supernal thighs,[B] and by the conclusion of the body, one should arrange one's table in this world before God and before the supernal Faces. For this reason they said that it was called the Showbread because it draws from the supernal Faces. And every table requires words of Torah and a portion for the poor, as it is written, "and satisfy the afflicted soul" (Isaiah 58:10), and afterward "then you shall delight in the Lord" (Isaiah 58:14) from all those delights that flow to that supernal glory. And it is said in Parashat Terumah, page 156b, that there is a table for the righteous in that world, and the food and provision of delight that they eat in that world[C] is like what the supernal angels eat. This is what the Israelites ate in the wilderness, and this is the secret

[A] Or: "a celestial golden table" — The Aramaic term 'patura d'dahava' has a mystical connotation that goes beyond a mere physical golden table. It refers specifically to a celestial or metaphysical table of gold that exists in higher spiritual realms as a reward for the righteous. This translation better captures the otherworldly nature of this concept.

[B] Or: "by the supernal supports" — While 'ירכין' literally means 'thighs,' in kabbalistic context this anatomical metaphor refers to cosmic supporting structures or pillars. A less literal translation would obscure the body metaphor that is important in kabbalistic literature, but might be more accessible to readers unfamiliar with these mystical anthropomorphisms.

[C] Or: "the spiritual sustenance and delight that they experience in that world" — The 'eating' described here is not physical consumption but a metaphor for spiritual absorption or experience. This alternate translation moves away from the literal food imagery to emphasize the non-physical nature of this sustenance, though at the cost of losing the deliberate parallel between physical and spiritual eating.

as sacred labor with spiritual compensation in the World to Come.

[1] This alludes to the rabbinic teaching in Pirkei Avot (Ethics of the Fathers) 4:2 that one should be 'as scrupulous about a minor mitzvah as about a major one, for you do not know the reward given for the respective mitzvot.'

[2] The imagery of a 'golden table' (פתורא דדהבא) in the World to Come builds on the biblical Showbread table but transforms it into a mystical reward. The three Patriarchs as 'supports' reflects the kabbalistic concept that Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob correspond to the divine attributes that sustain creation.

[i] This refers to a mystical 'golden table' in the afterlife that is supported by the merit of the three Patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob). In Kabbalistic thought, the Patriarchs correspond to the divine attributes of Chesed (Loving-kindness), Gevurah (Strength), and Tiferet (Beauty).

[ii] The text describes mystical nourishment in the World to Come as comparable to what angels consume. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that physical eating in this world has a spiritual counterpart in higher realms.

נזונים סוד נשמות הצדיקים
בג״ע ומתהנים שם שמשם נשמות
מתלבשות בגן כמו שהיו בעולם
הזה ומתפשטים ממנו בשבתות
ובמועדים ועולים לראות בכבוד
מאריהון[i] ולהתעדן בעדן עליון.
ופירוש יבא כל בשר כי כל זה
הוא רוח השולט על הגוף הנקרא
כל בשר כמו שכ״ל עליון נכנס
בגוף עליון וזהו ויתרון ארץ
בכל הוא וזהו יבא כ״ל בשר
לא הבשר דוקא ועל עידון זה
כתיב עין לא ראתה. וכל העוסק
בתורה על שלחנו יהב תוקפא
למאריה ומלאך סוריא נטיל כל
אינון מלין ושוי דיוקנא דההוא
שלחן קמי קב״ה[ii] ושלחן בזה
מטהר לאדם מכל עונותיו ומזכה
אותו לטוב עליון לעולם הבא
וצורך תקון עליון הוא שדברי
תורה יהיו נשמעים על השלחן
קודם ברכת המזון. ומזכהו
למזון עולם הזה ונזכר לטוב
קמי עתיק יומין ומוסיף כח וחיל
במקום שצריך [iii]

of the dew that flows and extends from the secret of the World to Come.[1] From there, the secret of the souls of the righteous in the Garden of Eden[A] are nourished and take pleasure, for from there souls are clothed in the garden as they were in this world. And they divest themselves of it on Sabbaths and festivals, and ascend to behold the glory of their Master and to delight in the supernal Eden. And the interpretation of "all flesh shall come"[2] (Isaiah 66:23) is that this is the spirit that rules over the body, which is called "all flesh," just as the supernal ALL enters the supernal body. This is the meaning of "the advantage of the land is in all"[3] (Ecclesiastes 5:8), and this is why it says "ALL flesh shall come," not specifically the flesh. And concerning this delight it is written, "No eye has seen it" (Isaiah 64:3). And whoever engages in Torah study at his table gives strength to his Master, and the angel Suriah takes all those words and places the image of that table before the Holy One, blessed be He. Such a table purifies a person from all his sins and merits him supernal goodness in the World to Come. It is necessary for supernal rectification that words of Torah be heard at the table before the Grace After Meals. This merits him sustenance in this world, and he is remembered favorably before the Ancient

[A] Or: "the essence of the righteous souls in the Garden of Eden" — The Hebrew 'סוד' (secret) can sometimes refer to the inner essence or fundamental nature of something, not merely something hidden. This translation might better capture the meaning in context, suggesting the innermost reality of these souls, though it loses the technical kabbalistic connotation of 'secret' as a mystical dimension.

[1] In kabbalistic thought, 'dew' (טל) is associated with resurrection and divine sustenance. It has a numerical value of 39, which connects it to various mystical formulas. The author is suggesting that the manna eaten by the Israelites was actually a manifestation of this spiritual dew from higher realms.

[2] The author is reinterpreting Isaiah 66:23 ('All flesh shall come to worship before Me') to suggest that 'all flesh' refers not to physical bodies but to the spiritual essence (רוח) that animates and rules over flesh. This aligns with the text's general approach of finding spiritual meanings behind physical descriptions.

[3] The Hebrew word for 'all' (כל) is treated as a technical term in Kabbalah, often associated with the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation). The author is connecting this verse from Ecclesiastes with the concept that divine blessing flows through this cosmic 'ALL' into the physical world.

[i] This describes a kabbalistic concept that on Sabbaths and festivals, souls in the Garden of Eden temporarily divest themselves of their 'garden garments' to ascend to higher spiritual levels and behold divine glory directly.

[ii] Suriah is an angel mentioned in kabbalistic literature who is responsible for carrying the words of Torah spoken at one's table and presenting them before God. This illustrates the belief that spiritual entities mediate between human religious activities and divine realms.

[iii] Cf. Garden of Eden — The passage continues the book's exploration of the Garden of Eden as both an afterlife destination and a spiritual source. It specifically adds the concept that righteous souls there continue to perform spiritual versions of Torah and commandments, suggesting a

of Days, and adds power and strength in the place where it is needed.

ובזה יזכה לשלחן הגדול משלחנם של גדולים. ועל הכל יכוין בברכת המזון לתקון עליון ועיין בזה בפרשת תרומה קכ״ד וקנ״ז. ושם אמר דצריך לומר מזמור על נהרות בבל על השלחן ועיין בדף ק״ט בכוונת ד׳ ברכות וסמיכותן ובע״ב ביאר ההוא רביא סדר ז׳ ברכות החופה וסמיכותן ואמר כי רצון השכינה שכל העולם ישאלון מזונות שהיא מקבלת בראשונה ע״כ הלהגנו לבקש רחמים על המזונות אפי׳ בשבת כנראה בסדר יום ראשון ממעירי שחר כי זה נקרא צורך גבוה ושם פירש מה הוא הקושי ליתן מזונות לעולם וקושי קריעת ים סוף וכן קשים זווגים ושם בדף קע״א ועמוד ב׳ וע״ג ביאר דרוש על סדר הככבים יע״ש וכלן לצורך מעשה הצדיקים. ובעולם הזה העושי מצות נאחזים בעלים הנובלים מאילן עץ החיים וכל מעשה המצות בשעתו עולה וכותב עצמו שם בטרפי האילן

In this way, one will merit the great table, greater than the tables of the great ones.[1] In all of this, one should direct their intention during the Grace After Meals toward supernal rectification. See about this in Parashat Terumah, pages 124 and 157. There it states that one must recite Psalm 137 ("By the rivers of Babylon") at the table, and see on page 109 regarding the intention of the four blessings and their connection. On page 72, that youth explained the order of the seven blessings of the wedding canopy and their connections, stating that it is the Divine Presence's will that the entire world should request sustenance, which She receives first. Therefore, we persist in requesting mercy for sustenance even on the Sabbath, as appears in the order for the first day in our "Illuminators of Dawn,"[2] for this is called "a higher need." There it explains what is the difficulty in providing sustenance to the world, the difficulty of splitting the Red Sea, and likewise how difficult matchmaking is. And there on page 171, column 2 and 3, a discourse on the order of the stars is explained—see there—and all of them are for the purpose of the righteous ones' deeds.

In this world, those who perform commandments grasp onto the leaves that fall from the Tree of Life,[3] and every act of a commandment, at its time,

[1] This is a metaphorical reference to spiritual reward, where the 'table' represents divine sustenance and blessing in both this world and the next. The comparison to 'tables of the great ones' suggests surpassing even the spiritual rewards of renowned sages.

[2] This appears to be a reference to the author's own prayer collection. Aaron Berechia of Modena seems to have compiled prayers for different occasions, including special requests for sustenance that were permitted even on Sabbath due to their spiritual significance.

[3] The author presents a mystical interpretation where mitzvot (commandments) create tangible spiritual realities depicted as 'leaves' from the cosmic Tree of Life. This connects physical religious actions with their supernal counterparts and effects.

continuity between religious practice in this world and the next. | Cf. Table imagery — The text draws parallels between the biblical Showbread table from the Temple, an individual's dining table in this world, and a metaphysical 'golden table' in the World to Come. This creates a mystical continuum where everyday dining practices connect to both ancient Temple rituals and future spiritual rewards. | Cf. Zohar Terumah 156b — The author explicitly cites this Zohar passage to establish the concept of a special table for the righteous in the afterlife. This reference authenticates his teaching about the continuity between physical and spiritual nourishment across different planes of existence. | Cf. Isaiah 58:10-14 — The text quotes from Isaiah to establish that sharing with the poor (material charity) leads to spiritual delight. This supports the author's central argument that physical actions in this world create corresponding spiritual realities in the next. | Cf. Israelites eating manna in the wilderness — By connecting the heavenly food of the righteous with the manna eaten by the Israelites, the author suggests that the manna was not merely physical sustenance but a manifestation of spiritual nourishment from higher realms, foreshadowing what the righteous will experience in the World to Come.

שבתוך הגן. ונלע״ד ראיה
לדרוש זה מטרפי דעלי שהזמין
אליהו בגלימיה דרבה בר אבוה
במציעא פרק המקבל ובתר
כן שמע קלא דהוה אמר מאן
אכיל לעלמיה בחייוהי כרבה
בר אבוה.[i] וזהו ספר המתקיים
עמהם אך אינו מתראה לעין
פמליא של מעלה וכ״ש למה
שלמטה מהם רק ביום ראש
השנה שבכח הגברת האש והדין
המתרבה באותו יום למעלה
בכסא מעשה הצדיקים והרשעים
שמידי יום ביום נכתבים זה
בחלק הטוב שבעץ הדעת טוב
וזה בחלק הרע שבו אינו נקרא
ונראה עד יום ר״ה כמשל
הכתיבה העשויה מאיזה מי
פירות כגון המיץ של לימוני
שאין מתראה מה שכתוב בו
עד כי יקריבוהו אצל האש כן
בר״ה ג׳ מיני ספרים נפתחים
שהם ג׳ מיני אוירים ספיריים
אחד לצד ימין בחלק הטוב
שבעולם מטטרון והוא מעשי
הצדיקים ואויר ספיריי אחד
שמצד שמאל בחלק הרע שבעץ
הדעת טוב ורע ומשם יניקתו
וכחו של ס״מ וחיילותיו ובו
נרשם ונכתב מעשיהם של רשעים
בסוד האפר שאינו עושה פירות
ואויר דביני וביני חציו לצד
מטטרון וחציו לצד ס״מ בו כתוב
ורשום מעשיהם של בינונים ובכח
האש הגדול המתלהט עליהם
מכח עולם הכסא דכל נשמתין

ascends and writes itself there on the leaves of the tree within the garden. It seems to me there is proof for this interpretation from the leaves that Elijah prepared in his cloak for Rabbah bar Avuha in Bava Metzia, chapter "The Receiver," after which he heard a voice saying, "Who has consumed his world during his lifetime like Rabbah bar Avuha?"[1] This is the book that remains with them, but it is not visible to the eye of the heavenly entourage—and certainly not to those below them—except on Rosh Hashanah, when, through the power of the intensifying fire and judgment on that day above in the Throne, the deeds of the righteous and the wicked, which are written day by day—these in the good part of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, and these in the evil part of it—are not read and seen until the day of Rosh Hashanah. It is like the parable of writing made from some fruit juice,[2] such as lemon juice, where what is written in it is not visible until it is brought near the fire. Similarly, on Rosh Hashanah, three types of books are opened, which are three types of ethereal atmospheres: one to the right side in the good part of the world of Metatron, containing the deeds of the righteous; and one ethereal atmosphere to the left side in the evil part of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, from which Samael and his forces draw their nourishment and power, and in which the deeds of the wicked are inscribed and written according to the mystery of ash, which does not produce fruit;[3] and an atmosphere in between, half toward Metatron and half toward Samael, in which the deeds of the intermediate ones are written and inscribed. And through the power of the great fire that blazes upon them from the power of the world of the Throne, from which all holy souls are

[1]This refers to the exceptional case of someone experiencing in this world the spiritual pleasures typically reserved for the World to Come. The author uses this to show how the 'leaves' of good deeds can provide spiritual sustenance even in this life.

[2]The author uses the metaphor of invisible ink (lemon juice) that only becomes visible when heated to explain how human deeds, though recorded constantly, only become 'visible' to divine judgment on Rosh Hashanah through the intensification of supernal fire.

[3]This metaphor contrasts with the 'leaves' and 'fruit' imagery used for righteous deeds. The wicked deeds are recorded as 'ash,' symbolizing their spiritual sterility and inability to generate positive spiritual consequences.

[i]This refers to a Talmudic story (Bava Metzia 114b) where Rabbah bar Avuha encountered Elijah in a cemetery and benefited from divine pleasure in his lifetime. The author uses this story to demonstrate that the spiritual rewards normally reserved for the afterlife can sometimes be experienced in this world by the exceptionally righteous.

קדישין מתמן אתגזרו מביום הרת
עולם שמלך המשפט יושב על
הכסא וכל באי עולם מתראים
לפניו בכל בחינותיהם חצוניים
ופנימיים וכל צבא השמים
עומדים עליו אז כרגע בכח
מדת הדין האוקר כל נסתרות
יוצא לגילוי רושם מעשים אלו
דוגמא לזו אמרו בתקון דף ע״א
ע״ב וגוונין אלו נהריו ברקיעא
עד דיעול תמן קב״ה כי אז
נאמר נפתחו השמים ואראה
מראות אלהים וידוע כי כסא
הכבוד מתעלה ומתהדר במעשה
התחתונים ומשמח בתולת ישראל
במחול שלו בשלהבת שתמיד
מתנועעת כלפי מעלה וזה כי
תאב להתדבק בעילתו בכח
קשוטי התחתונים המתראים בו.
לכן בשעת התפלה טוב לנענע
עצמו דרך ימין ושמאל לרמז
התעוררות הכסא ואמרי׳ בפ׳
תרומה דף קנ״ד ע״א כורסא
קדישא לא אתקן לעיל אלא מגו
תקונא דבני עלמא[i] כד אינון
זכאין וחסידין וידעין לתקנא
תקונוהי וזהו כל הנקרא בשמי
ולכבודי בראתיו. וכ״ש עולם
היצירה והעשיה. ובזהר החדש
במדרש הנעלם דף ל״ב תנו רבנן
כשאדם הולך בדרכי קונו הרבה
מסייעים אותו ונשמתו מלאכי
השרת שכיצה וכלם מכריזים
לפניו בלכתך לא יצר צעדך
וגו׳. ובסדר שלש מיני אוירין
אלו נבין פירוש שלשה ספרים
נפתחים[ii] לא אמר נכתבים שכבר
הם כתובים כל א׳ בשעת מעשה
ברם ביום הדין כי הנה ה׳
באש יבא[iii] נפתחים שמתראה

hewn, from the day of the world's creation when the King of Judgment sits on the Throne and all who enter the world appear before Him in all their aspects, external and internal, and all the host of heaven stand over Him—then, in an instant, through the power of the attribute of Judgment which investigates all secrets, the imprint of these deeds comes to revelation.

Similar to this, they said in Tikkunim, page 71b, "These colors shine in the firmament until the Holy One, blessed be He, enters there," for then it is said, "The heavens opened and I saw visions of God." And it is known that the Throne of Glory is elevated and glorified through the deeds of those below, and gladdens the virgin of Israel in His dance, like a flame that always moves upward, because it yearns to cling to its cause through the power of the adornments of those below that appear in it. Therefore, during prayer, it is good to move oneself right and left to symbolize the arousal of the Throne. And it says in Parashat Terumah, page 154a, "The holy throne is not established above except through the rectification by the people of the world when they are meritorious and pious and know how to establish its rectifications," and this is "Everyone who is called by My name, for My glory I have created him." And how much more so the world of Formation and the world of Action.

And in the New Zohar, in the Hidden Midrash, page 32, the Rabbis taught: "When a person walks in the ways of his Creator, many assist him—his soul, the ministering angels, the Divine Presence—and all of them proclaim before him, 'When you go, your steps shall not be impeded,' etc." And in the order of these three types of atmospheres, we can understand the interpretation of "three books are opened"—it does not say "written," for they are already written, each one at the time of the deed. However, on the day of judgment, for behold, "the Lord will come with fire," they are opened so that what is hinted at in them becomes visible and articulated through

[i] This Zoharic teaching explains that the divine throne (symbolizing God's sovereignty) is established through human righteous actions. The author uses this to demonstrate how human deeds directly affect supernal realms.

[ii] This refers to the rabbinic teaching that on Rosh Hashanah, three books are opened: one for the completely righteous, one for the completely wicked, and one for those in between. The author provides a kabbalistic interpretation of this concept, explaining these 'books' as three types of ethereal atmospheres where human deeds are recorded.

[iii] This is a reference to Isaiah 66:15, which describes divine judgment coming with fire. The author uses this biblical imagery to explain how the 'hidden writing' of human deeds becomes visible

ונהגה מה שנרמז בהם בכח אש
גלילי הכסא הרובץ עליהם
וכמו שהעתידות בדעת עליון
לא יחייבו הטוב והרע כן רושם
שבאוירים אלו לא יחייבו מיתה
וחיים לבעליהם עד כי יתראו
למטה בסוד הכתיבה שהכתיבה
היא הויה נגלית כדבר הנגבל
בספר על ידי הכתיבה וסוד
הכתיבה היא במלכות יד החזקה
החתימה היא באימא יד הגדולה
וכלא כ״ח פרקים ויש עוד יד
רמה כנדרש בתקון נ״ה דף
צ״ב בעולם המלאכים כתביאל
ממונה על הכתיבה. חתמיאל
על החתימה כתביאל מסטרא
דאימא חתמיאל מסטרא דחכמה
ותרווייהו חיים בהו ג׳ אצבעות
מתייחדים לקולמוס לכתיבה
ועליהם אמר בן זומא אין בין
מים העליונים לתחתונים אלא
בג׳ אצבעות[i] ושנים סומכים
להני ה״א תתאה כותב באות וא״ו
שהוא קולמוס קנה הזרוע ה״א
עילאה חותם באות יו״ד שהוא
כף היד ובסוף תקון י׳ וגם בתקון
י״ח דורש בכתיבה וחתימה פוק
חזי. וכתיב באדם ותפקדנו
לבקרים לרגעים תבחננו[ii] וזה
שמלבד דין ראש השנה בנזכר
[iii] עוד יש דין המות

the power of the fiery rings of the Throne resting upon them. And just as future events in supernal knowledge do not determine good and evil, so too the impressions in these atmospheres do not determine death and life for their owners until they appear below in the mystery of the writing. For writing is a revealed existence, like something bounded in a book through writing. And the mystery of writing is in Malkhut, "the strong hand"; the sealing is in Imma, "the great hand"; and all are 28 joints. And there is also "the uplifted hand," as interpreted in Tikkun 55, page 92. In the world of angels, Kataviel is appointed over writing, Chatamiel over sealing. Kataviel is from the side of Imma, Chatamiel from the side of Chokhmah, and both are living. In them, three fingers unite for the pen for writing, and regarding them Ben Zoma said, "There is nothing between the upper waters and the lower waters except three fingers," and two support them. The lower Hei writes with the letter Vav, which is the pen, the reed of the arm; the upper Hei seals with the letter Yod, which is the palm of the hand. And at the end of Tikkun 10, and also in Tikkun 18, he expounds on writing and sealing—go and see. And it is written concerning humans, "You remember him every morning, You test him every moment." This means that apart from the judgment of Rosh Hashanah mentioned above, there is also the judgment of death.

through the intensification of divine fire on the day of judgment.

[i] This quotes a teaching from Ben Zoma in Genesis Rabbah 2:4 about the separation between upper and lower waters in creation. The author recontextualizes this to explain the metaphysical process of writing in the heavenly books, where three fingers unite for the cosmic 'pen.'

[ii] This is a quotation from Job 7:18. The author uses this verse to establish that divine judgment occurs not only annually on Rosh Hashanah but also continuously, with daily examinations of human deeds.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The passage references specific pages in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, regarding the spiritual significance of blessing after meals and its effects on supernal worlds. These references provide detailed kabbalistic explanations of how human actions below create cosmic effects above. | Cf. Psalm 137 (By the rivers of Babylon) — The text prescribes reciting this psalm during meals, connecting the mundane act of eating with the redemptive themes of the psalm. This unexpected connection suggests a kabbalistic view that table rituals can help rectify the cosmic exile. | Cf. Bava Metzia — The reference to Elijah preparing leaves in his cloak for Rabbah bar Avuha alludes to a Talmudic story (Bava Metzia 114b) where Rabbah encounters Elijah in a cemetery. The author uses this as proof that righteous actions create tangible spiritual 'leaves' that can be 'consumed' or experienced even in this world. | Cf. Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil — This biblical reference (Genesis 2-3) is reinterpreted in kabbalistic terms to represent a cosmic structure where human deeds are recorded. The author presents a tripartite division of this tree, with righteous deeds recorded on the good side, wicked deeds on the evil side, and intermediate

ומי שהגיע זמנו למות קודם
ר״ה[i] אז מעשיו בכח הדין
שדנין אותו[ii] נכתבין ונחתמין
למעלה:[iii iv]

And for one whose time to die arrives before Rosh Hashanah, his deeds are written and sealed above[1] through the power of judgment[2] that judges him.

פרק ל״א

Chapter 31

מה שאמרנו בפרק הקודם
שהצדיקים נאחזים בעלים
הנובלות מאילן עץ החיים
בסוד נובלת חכמה של מעלה
תורה[v] זהו בעוה״ז אך אחר
שמתעלים ומתאחדים בעולם

What we said in the previous chapter—that the righteous cling to the leaves that fall from the Tree of Life, in the mystery of[3] "the fallen fruit of supernal wisdom is Torah"[A]—this applies to this world. But after they ascend and unite in the World of Souls, there they merit to enjoy the very essence of the light

[A] Or: "Torah is the withered leaves of supernal wisdom" — The term 'novelet' (נובלה) can refer to fallen leaves or withered fruit. This alternate translation emphasizes the hierarchical relationship between celestial wisdom and earthly Torah, suggesting Torah is a more distant derivative of divine wisdom.

[1] The term "above" (למעלה/l'maalah) has mystical significance in kabbalistic texts, referring to the celestial realms where divine judgment occurs. The author is describing a metaphysical process of recording the deceased's deeds in the heavenly books.

[2] I've rendered "בכח הדין" as "through the power of judgment" to convey the kabbalistic concept that divine judgment is an active force or power that processes the soul after death, not merely a passive evaluation.

[3] The Hebrew term 'besod' (בסוד) literally means 'in the secret of' and is commonly used in kabbalistic texts to introduce an esoteric interpretation. I've translated it as 'in the mystery of' to maintain the mystical connotation.

deeds in between. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) — The author references his own prayer collection, indicating that this composition likely contained specific prayers and kavvanot (spiritual intentions) for requesting sustenance, even on Sabbath when mundane requests are typically discouraged. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The citation from Tikkunei Zohar about colors shining in the firmament connects to the author's explanation of how human deeds become visible on Rosh Hashanah. This reference supports the kabbalistic concept that human actions create visible 'colors' or effects in supernal realms. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:1 — The quotation 'The heavens opened and I saw visions of God' comes from Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot. The author uses this to illustrate how divine judgment works through revelation—just as Ezekiel's vision involved an opening of heavens, the judgment process involves an 'opening' of cosmic books.

[i] Abbreviation for Rosh Hashanah, the Jewish New Year and day of judgment.

[ii] This phrase carries kabbalistic significance, referring to the power of divine judgment that becomes activated for an individual at death. In the cosmology of Ma'avar Yabok, each person's death triggers a personalized judgment process.

[iii] The metaphor of "writing and sealing" derives from the Rosh Hashanah liturgy where God is described as writing and sealing the fate of all living beings. Here, it's applied to an individual judgment process at death, using the same celestial record-keeping imagery.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section 4.4 — This text connects to an earlier discussion in Ma'avar Yabok about the three books opened on Rosh Hashanah. Here, the author explains what happens to those who die before the annual judgment day—they undergo an individual judgment process where their deeds are recorded in the celestial ledger outside the regular annual cycle. | Cf. Talmud, Rosh Hashanah 16a-b — This passage builds on the Talmudic concept that three books are opened on Rosh Hashanah: one for the completely righteous, one for the completely wicked, and one for those in between. The author adapts this concept to explain the status of those who die before this annual judgment day.

[v] This phrase refers to a rabbinic teaching that Torah in this world is merely the 'fallen fruit' or residue of the supernal wisdom. It appears in Genesis Rabbah 17:5, where Rabbi Abbahu states, 'Torah is only the fallen fruit of the supernal wisdom.'

הנשמות שם זוכים ליהנות מעצם
האור המתהוה מאור הקדום
שתמיד עושה פירות לצדיקים
שנאמר אור זרוע לצדיק[i] כנראה
בזהר פ׳ תרומה דף קמ״ט
דאור זה אזדרע כהאי זרעא
דעביד תולדין וזרעין ואיבין
ומיניה אתקיים עלמא ואמר כי
הענן ששכן על המשכן[ii] היה
מסטרא דאור קדמאה וגם
שאינו נגלה ממנו מחדש בכל
יום מעשה בראשות וחדוש זה
הוא למעלה מן השמש בגן עדן
שבעליית שם הצדיקים מתרבים
בו בכל עת האורות ושם עוסקים
ומשתעשעים בפירות אילן עץ
החיים וזהו כוונת הפסוק אמרו
צדיק כי טוב כי פרי מעלליהם
יאכלו. ואמרו שכל מעשינו
בעה״ז הם תהו ואפי׳ מעשה
המצות[iii] [iv]

that emanates from the Primordial Light, which constantly produces fruits for the righteous, as it is said, "Light is sown for the righteous" (Psalms 97:11). As appears in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 149, where it states that this light is sown like a seed that produces offspring, seeds, and fruits,[1] and from it the world is sustained. And it says that the cloud that dwelled over the Tabernacle came from the aspect of the Primordial Light, and though it is not revealed from it, it renews the work of Creation every day. And this renewal occurs above the sun, in the Garden of Eden, where through the ascension of the righteous there, the lights increase at all times, and there they engage and delight in the fruits of the Tree of Life. This is the meaning of the verse, "Say of the righteous that it shall be well with them, for they shall eat the fruit of their deeds" (Isaiah 3:10). And they said that all our deeds in this world are vanity,[A] even the performance of commandments.

[A] Or: "emptiness" — The Hebrew term 'tohu' (תהו) could also be translated as 'emptiness' or 'formlessness', which might better capture its cosmological significance in kabbalistic thought, where it refers to an unformed state of potential rather than mere futility.

[1] The original Hebrew uses Aramaic terms from the Zohar: 'azdara' (is sown), 'avid toladin' (produces offspring), 'zar'in' (seeds), and 'eibin' (fruits). This agricultural metaphor is central to the passage's understanding of how divine light generates ongoing spiritual benefits.

[i] This is a quotation from Psalms 97:11, 'Light is sown for the righteous.' The author interprets this verse as indicating that divine light is planted like a seed that produces ongoing spiritual fruits for the righteous in the afterlife.

[ii] This refers to the cloud of divine glory that rested on the Tabernacle in the wilderness, as described in Exodus 40:34-38. The author, following the Zohar, interprets this cloud as an emanation of the Primordial Light.

[iii] This is a striking statement that all deeds in this world, even the performance of divine commandments, are considered 'vanity' or 'emptiness' (תהו). This does not mean they are worthless, but rather that they are incomplete or unfinished compared to their perfected form in the World to Come.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 149 — The reference to the Zohar Terumah elaborates on the metaphor of divine light as something that is 'sown' and grows like seeds, producing spiritual fruits. This metaphor establishes that righteous actions generate ongoing spiritual benefits in higher realms, supporting the text's main argument about the eternal rewards of the righteous in the World of Souls. | Cf. Psalms 97:11 — The citation 'Light is sown for the righteous' (Psalms 97:11) serves as a biblical foundation for the kabbalistic concept that divine light generates ongoing rewards for the righteous. The author interprets this verse to indicate that divine illumination is not merely passively received but actively cultivated like seeds that produce fruits. | Cf. Isaiah 3:10 — The quote from Isaiah about the righteous eating 'the fruit of their deeds' reinforces the central metaphor of the passage that righteous actions produce spiritual 'fruits' that sustain the souls of the righteous in the afterlife. This scriptural citation legitimizes the author's kabbalistic interpretation of the afterlife experience.

ותהו הוא דבר שאינו מושלם וצריך תקון וכטעם ה׳ יגמור בעדי.[i] ועצה טובה לאדם שיתפוס מצוה אחת לפחות בקנין גמור ויתמיד ויזרז בה כל ימיו ואל יניחנה מלעשותה אפי׳ בשביל ממון הרבה. כי היא מקדמתו והולכת לפניו לעה״ב כההוא דהוה גמיר מסכת חגיגה לבד[ii] שהובא במדרש רבי תנחומא ואמרו בקדושין פ״ק מי שיחד לו מצוה ולא עבר עליה כל ימיו זה נקרא עושה מצוה אחת שמטיבין לו ומאריכין את ימיו ואל ימנע אדם עצמו ואפי׳ יהיה השעה דחוקה לו מליתן בכל יום ששה או לפחות ארבעה פרוטות לצדקה ואם יהיה בשעת תפלה מה טוב ויפריד אותם בעת אומרו פסוק פותח את ידיך[iii] וישימם בקופה או יתנם לעני בעת אמירת ובא לציון ובבוקר כי היא תוספת קדושה וכל מקום שיש קדושה חצוני בורח שאין מקום לחצוני אלא לפתח או בגדרות[iv] אמנם פנימה בקדש אין שליטתו והיא מגן לתפלה שלא יזנב אחריה עמלק ראש צרים[v] והקדושה נמשכת ממקום הקדש מלמעלה ותרד

And [this term] "tohu" (void/chaos[1]) refers to something that is incomplete and requires rectification, in the sense of "The Lord will fulfill [His purpose] for me." Good advice for a person is to grasp at least one commandment with complete acquisition, persisting and being zealous in it all their days, never abandoning its performance even for great wealth. For it precedes him and goes before him to the World to Come, like that case of one who only mastered the tractate of Chagigah, as brought in the Midrash of Rabbi Tanchuma. And they said in the first chapter of Kiddushin: "One who designates a particular commandment for himself and never transgresses it throughout his life, this person is called 'one who performs a single commandment,' for whom good is done and whose days are lengthened."

A person should not withhold from himself, even if his circumstances are difficult, from giving six or at least four small coins to charity every day. If this can be done during prayer, how good that is! One should set these coins aside when reciting the verse "You open Your hand" and place them in the charity box, or give them to a poor person when saying "And a redeemer shall come to Zion," particularly in the morning, as this adds holiness. Wherever there is holiness, external [negative] forces flee,[2] for these external forces have no place except at the entrance or in the boundaries. But within the holy place itself, they have no dominion. This practice serves as a shield for prayer, preventing Amalek, the chief of adversaries,

[1] The Hebrew term 'tohu' comes from Genesis 1:2 describing primordial chaos. The author gives it a mystical interpretation as something incomplete requiring spiritual rectification (tikkun).

[2] In kabbalistic thought, acts of holiness create a spiritual boundary that repels negative forces (chitzonim). The author is describing how the simple act of giving charity during prayer creates such a protective shield.

[i] This is a quote from Psalm 138:8, 'The LORD will fulfill His purpose for me,' which the author uses to explain the concept of 'tohu' (chaos/void) as something incomplete that requires divine completion.

[ii] The author references a story from Midrash Tanchuma about someone who had mastered only the Talmudic tractate Chagigah, suggesting that even limited Torah knowledge, if pursued consistently, has great spiritual value.

[iii] This refers to Psalm 145:16, 'You open Your hand and satisfy the desire of every living thing,' which appears in the daily prayers. The author recommends this moment for setting aside charity, creating a symbolic connection between God's generosity and human generosity.

[iv] The term 'chitzonim' (external ones) refers to negative spiritual forces in Kabbalistic terminology. The author is explaining that these forces cannot penetrate places of true holiness but can only exist at the boundaries or entrances.

[v] Amalek is traditionally viewed in Jewish thought as the archetypal enemy of Israel and spirituality. The author uses this symbolism to represent the negative spiritual forces that might attack after prayer if not properly guarded against.

עד סוף המדרגות שהוא לבית
חצוני טהור סוד התרגום[i] ואז
הוא עת רצון להמשיך השפע
מצדק לצדקה[ii] לעשות מגן וצנה
לקדושה ולהרבות השפע ולשים
הצדקה בקופה. ובמנחה יקדים
הצדקה לתפלה דכתיב אני
בצדק אחזה פניך[iii] ולא יעבור
שום יום מימיו שלא יתן צדקה
אם מעט ואם הרבה ובערב
שבת וי״ט יתן כפלים. ומי
שאינו יודע לקבוע עתים לתורה
שבעל פה ירגיל עצמו במעמדות
הנסדרות[iv] ויקרא כל ימיו
לפחות העשרים וארבע בכל שנה
במיתון ובטעמים וכבר ברחמי
שמים הורגלו בן פה בעירנו
בעלי בתים הרבה ישמרם ה׳ ומי
שאפי׳ זה אינו יודע ירגיל עצמו
לקרות ספר תהלים לפחות פעם
אחת בכל חדש ובפרט קודם
שילך על מטתו ואמרו במדרש
כי יעקב אבינו בבית לבן היה
עוסק בספר תהלים[v] כי הבא
ליטהר בעה״ז מסייעים אותו
לעה״ב ויפה כח הסיוע לעה״ב
וכן פתחי לי אחותי פתח כחודה

from attacking from behind. Holiness flows from the holy place above and descends to the lowest levels, which is the realm of the pure external, the secret of the Aramaic translation. This becomes a favorable time to draw divine flow from Tzedek (righteousness) to Tzedakah (charity),[1] creating a shield and buckler for holiness, increasing divine flow, and placing charity in the collection box. 60R

For the afternoon prayer, one should give charity before praying, as it is written: "Through righteousness shall I behold Your face."[2] No day of one's life should pass without giving charity, whether little or much, and on the eve of Sabbath and festivals, one should give double. 65R

One who does not know how to set fixed times for studying the Oral Torah should accustom himself to the established Ma'amadot prayers[3] and read through the twenty-four books [of the Bible] each year, carefully and with proper cantillation. By God's mercy, many householders in our city have already developed this habit—may God protect them. And one who doesn't even know how to do this should accustom himself to reading the Book of Psalms at least once every month, especially before going to bed. They said in the Midrash that our father Jacob, while in Laban's house, occupied himself with the Book of Psalms,[4] for one who comes 70R 75R 80R

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that human actions create corresponding movements in divine realms. Here, the act of charity below draws spiritual energy from the divine attribute of Tzedek above.

[2] The author is making a practical application of Psalm 17:15, suggesting that giving charity before the afternoon prayer spiritually prepares one to 'behold God's face' through prayer.

[3] Ma'amadot are special prayers instituted to correspond to the daily Temple sacrifices. The author recommends these as accessible for those without advanced Torah knowledge.

[4] This anachronistic tradition (since Psalms is attributed to David, who lived much later than Jacob) illustrates the rabbinic concept that sacred texts spiritually pre-existed their formal composition.

[i] The 'secret of the translation' refers to the kabbalistic understanding that the Aramaic translation of scripture represents a lower level of holiness than the original Hebrew, yet still contains sanctity. This is used metaphorically to describe the outermost boundary of the sacred realm.

[ii] The author creates a mystical wordplay between 'tzedek' (righteousness, also a name for specific divine attributes in Kabbalah) and 'tzedakah' (charity), suggesting that the act of giving charity creates a channel for divine flow from higher spiritual realms.

[iii] This is a quote from Psalm 17:15, 'As for me, I shall behold Your face in righteousness.' The author interprets this as biblical support for giving charity before the afternoon prayer.

[iv] Ma'amadot are special prayers and Torah readings organized for each day of the week, corresponding to the daily Temple sacrifices. These were considered accessible for those without advanced Torah knowledge.

[v] This midrashic tradition about Jacob studying Psalms while in Laban's house is significant because Psalms is traditionally attributed to King David, who lived much later. The anachronism is reconciled in Jewish tradition by viewing the Psalms as spiritually pre-existing their formal composition.

של מחט[i] מתוך חשך העה״ז ואני אפתח לכם פתחים גדולים לעה״ב ובעולם שאחר המות וכתוב בסבא פ׳ משפטים דף צ״ו על פסוק יעשה למחכה לו כד האי ברתא אשלימת עשיה בהאי עלמא אוף הכי הקב״ה אשלים עשיה אחרא בעלמא דאתי דכתיב ביה עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך.[ii] ומקובלני כי הוא תקון גדול לעם הארץ לקרות בכל יום פרשת אותה שבוע או לפחות חצייה ובזה יזכה להגות בה גם הוא בג״ע.[iii]

to purify himself in this world receives assistance in the World to Come. The power of this assistance is beautiful for the World to Come, as in "Open for me, my sister"—if you open an entrance as narrow as the eye of a needle from within the darkness of this world, "I will open for you wide entrances" to the World to Come and the world after death. 85R

It is written in Saba (the Elder's teaching) in Parashat Mishpatim, page 96, on the verse "He acts for those who wait for Him": "When this daughter [the soul][1] completes her work in this world, so too does the Holy One, blessed be He, complete another work in the World to Come, concerning which it is written: 'No eye has seen it, O God, but You.'" I have received a tradition that it is a great rectification for a common person to read each day the Torah portion of that week, or at least half of it, and through this, he too will merit to meditate upon it in the Garden of Eden.[2] 90R 95R 100R

ומה שאמר המלך החכם כי אין מעשה וחשבון בשאול אשר אתה הולך שם ירצה כי היורד לשאול לפי שלא התחיל לטרוח בערב שבת בעה״ז כדאמרו במדרש כי

And regarding what the wise king [Solomon] said,[3] "For there is no work, nor device, nor knowledge, nor wisdom, in the grave, where you go" [Ecclesiastes 9:10]—he means that those who descend to Sheol, because they did not begin to 105R

[1] In kabbalistic texts, especially the Zohar, the soul is often referred to as a 'daughter,' reflecting its feminine grammatical gender in Hebrew (nefesh) and its receptive relationship to divine influence.
[2] In Jewish mystical thought, the Garden of Eden represents not just the biblical location but a spiritual realm where souls study Torah after death. The author suggests that Torah study in this world creates the ability to continue that study in the afterlife.
[3] The 'wise king' refers to King Solomon, traditionally considered the author of Ecclesiastes (Kohelet). The author begins with a biblical verse that seemingly contradicts his thesis, only to reinterpret it.

[i] This metaphor of opening 'like the eye of a needle' appears in several rabbinic texts, including Midrash Song of Songs Rabbah 5:2 and Pesikta Rabbati. It expresses the idea that even minimal human spiritual effort triggers enormous divine response.
[ii] This is a quote from Isaiah 64:3, describing the incomprehensible rewards reserved for the righteous in the World to Come. The author uses it to emphasize the divine response to human spiritual effort.
[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, introduction — This passage elaborates on one of the central themes of the entire work: how actions in this world create spiritual realities in the World to Come. The author recommends specific spiritual practices that create protection and spiritual merit. | Cf. Midrash Tanchuma — The author uses this reference to support his argument that even focusing on a single commandment or area of study can be spiritually powerful if done consistently. | Cf. Talmud Kiddushin, first chapter — This reference supports the author's practical advice to focus intensely on at least one mitzvah rather than attempting to master all commandments without consistency. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:2 — The author uses this verse from Song of Songs, interpreted mystically as dialogue between God and Israel, to illustrate how even minimal spiritual effort ('opening like the eye of a needle') will be met with divine abundance ('wide entrances'). | Cf. Zohar, Saba d'Mishpatim — This reference from the Zohar section known as 'Saba d'Mishpatim' (The Elder of Mishpatim) establishes the kabbalistic principle that human spiritual work in this world creates a corresponding divine response in the World to Come.

רשעי גהינם אומרים להקב״ה
הניחנו ונעשה תשובה והוא
משיב להם שוטים וכו׳[i] כדדרשו
על פסוק לא המתים יהללו
יה ולא כל יורדי דומה בראש
אידרת האזינו. להם אין מעשה
שם אבל הצדיקים שנטועים
ושתולים בעודם בעה״ז בבית
ה׳ בג״ע עליון ותחתון[ii] שהוא
מדורם אחר המות ומסלסלים
נטיעותיהם ושרשי נשמתם ששם
שם יפריחו וירטיבו מצות
ומעשים טובים רוחניים ויחודים
מופלאים בכח סתרי תורה
שיתחדש להם שם כי הנגלות הם
לנו ולבנינו פי׳ פשוטן של מצות
הנגלות הם לנו ולבנינו וזה
אינו אלא עד עולם פי׳ בעה״ז
כי אחר העולם גם הנסתרות
מה׳ אלהינו יתגלו לנו כי לא
ירעיב ה׳ נפש צדיק ולא לבד
יתקנו למעלה אחר המיתה כפי
מעשיהם אלא אפי׳ המעשה
הטוב והתקון שעלה במחשבתם
לתקן וליחד אבל מפני קוצר
המשיג ועומק המושג לא הספיקו
להוציא מחשבתם הטובה מן הכח
אל הפועל[iii] וכן כל מין מצוה
שחשב אדם בעה״ז ותאב בה
הרבה לעשותה ואפי׳ לא הספיק

labor on the eve of Sabbath while in this world, as stated in the Midrash: The wicked in Gehenna say to the Holy One, blessed be He,[1] "Leave us, and we will repent," but He responds to them, "Fools..." as they interpret the verse, "The dead do not praise the LORD, nor do any who go down into silence" [Psalm 115:17] at the beginning of Idra Ha'azinu. For them, there is no work there. But the righteous, who are planted and rooted while still in this world in the house of the LORD, in the upper and lower Garden of Eden—which becomes their dwelling after death—they cultivate their plantings and the roots of their souls,[2] which will there flourish and grow moist through spiritual commandments, good deeds, and wondrous unifications[3] through the power of Torah mysteries that will be revealed to them there. For "the revealed things belong to us and to our children" means: the plain meaning of the revealed commandments belongs to us and to our children, but this is only "forever" in this world. For after this world, even "the hidden things that belong to the LORD our God" [Deuteronomy 29:28] will be revealed to us, because the LORD will not starve the soul of the righteous.

And not only will they establish rectifications above after death according to their deeds, but even the good actions and rectifications that arose in their thoughts to rectify and unify, but which—due to the limitation of the perceiver and the depth of what is to be perceived—they did not manage to

[1] This refers to a rabbinic teaching that the wicked, after experiencing punishment in Gehenna, ask for another chance to repent, but are told it's too late. The author uses this to emphasize that spiritual work must be done during life.

[2] The author uses agricultural metaphors (planting, cultivating, flourishing) to describe ongoing spiritual development after death. This reflects the kabbalistic view that souls continue to grow and evolve in the afterlife.

[3] The 'wondrous unifications' (yichudim) refers to mystical practices in Kabbalah that unite various aspects of divinity. The author suggests that these spiritual techniques continue and are enhanced after death.

[i] The author is referencing a midrashic dialogue where the wicked in Gehenna ask God for a chance to repent after death, and God responds by calling them fools. This demonstrates the author's view that spiritual preparation must be done during life, not after death.

[ii] The author uses horticultural metaphors (planted, rooted) to illustrate that the righteous establish their spiritual connection to the Garden of Eden while still alive, which then becomes their dwelling after death. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that spiritual worlds are accessed through devotional practices during life.

[iii] The author introduces the significant kabbalistic principle that sincere spiritual intentions that could not be actualized due to human limitations are nevertheless credited to the righteous in the afterlife. This provides comfort regarding unfulfilled spiritual aspirations.

לקיימה מקבל עליה שכר בעה״ב
כמ״ש על הרהורי תשובה וזה
יקרא עמידה מכסא דין וישיבה
על כסא רחמים[i] כי אלהינו
מרחם משלם שכר כפי המחשבה
הזכה כמעשה וכתוב בפ׳ ויקהל
כי הרצון טוב מקדש כל אברי
הגוף והם ממשיכים עליה אור
השכינה בכמה עושר וברכות.
ואם תפלת האדם המך בעה״ז
עולה בכמה רקיעים ובכמה
עטרין וכל חיילין דכולהו
רקיעין סגדין לגבה ומעלין
אותה לרקיע שביעי ומשם על
ידי דסנדלפון רבא ויקירא
עילאה דכל מפתחאן דמריה
בידיה ואעיל לה תוך שבעה
היכלין ומחבר לון כחדא למהוי
חד[ii] ושמא דקוב״ה מתעטר בכל
סטרין עילא ותתא למיהוי חד
כדאיתא בפ׳ ויקהל ופקודי
ופ׳ בראשית מזה נובל להבין
כמה יהא רב גובריה מסוד
היחוד אשר יעלה מג״ע תחתון

bring from potential to actua[A]l, and likewise every type of commandment that a person contemplated in this world and greatly desired to perform, even if they did not manage to fulfill it, they receive reward for it in the World to Come, as stated regarding thoughts of repentance.[1] This is called rising from the throne of judgment and sitting on the throne of mercy,[B] for our God is merciful and rewards according to pure thought as if it were action.

And it is written in Parashat Vayakhel that good will sanctifies all the limbs of the body, and they draw upon it the light of the Divine Presence with much wealth and blessings. And if the prayer of a lowly person in this world ascends through several firmaments and through several crowns, and all the hosts of all the firmaments bow to it and elevate it to the seventh firmament, and from there, through the great and precious supernal Sandalphon,[2] who holds all the keys of his Master in his hand, and brings it into the seven palaces and joins them together as one, and the name of the Holy One, blessed be He, is crowned in all directions, above and below, to become one,[C] as stated in Parashat Vayakhel and Pekudei and Parashat Bereshit—from this, we can

[A] Or: "but even the good deeds and spiritual repairs they intended to perform but could not actualize—due to the limitations of human understanding and the profundity of divine mysteries—they were unable to transform their noble intentions from potential into reality" — This alternate translation uses more accessible language while still preserving the philosophical distinction between potential and actualization. It might be preferable for readers less familiar with kabbalistic terminology.

[B] Or: "This represents a transition from the divine attribute of strict justice to the divine attribute of compassion" — This alternate translation focuses more on the theological concept rather than the literal imagery of thrones. It might be preferable in contexts where readers are more interested in the theological principles than the metaphorical imagery.

[C] Or: "unifying them into a single entity, so that the divine name becomes crowned throughout all dimensions, celestial and terrestrial, achieving perfect unity" — This alternate translation renders the Aramaic phrases with slightly more technical precision regarding the kabbalistic concept of divine unification across cosmic dimensions. It might be preferable for scholarly analysis of the mystical concepts.

[1] This references the rabbinic teaching that sincere thoughts of repentance are counted as if the person had actually repented. The author extends this principle to all good intentions that couldn't be fulfilled due to circumstances.

[2] In Jewish mystical tradition, Sandalphon is an archangel who receives prayers and weaves them into crowns for God. The author describes the mystical process by which prayers ascend through cosmic realms.

[i] This phrase references the kabbalistic concept of God transitioning from the attribute of judgment (din) to the attribute of mercy (rachamim), suggesting that divine judgment of human actions is ultimately tempered by compassion.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase describes how the angel Sandalphon brings prayers through seven celestial palaces and unifies them. The author uses technical kabbalistic language from the Zohar to describe the journey of prayers through spiritual realms.

מסוד הרוח ומג״ע עליון בסוד הנשמה.[i] ששם מנוחתה וכ״ש בעליית הנשמה עצמה עם כל מרכבותיה ותקוניה וקשוטיה כמה נהורין סלקין ונחתין עמה.[ii]

understand how much greater will be the power of the unification that ascends from the lower Garden of Eden, from the mystery of the ruach, and from the upper Garden of Eden, from the mystery of the neshamah,[1] where it rests. And all the more so in the ascent of the neshamah itself, with all its chariots, rectifications, and adornments[2]—how many lights ascend and descend with it!

ומג״ע שהוא למעלה מהשמש[iii] מתחדש טובו בכל יום כי שמש ומגן ה׳ אלהים בעלמא דיליה ולא בעלמא דהדיוט[iv] והכל בסוד התעוררות העולה מן נפשות החיים[v] ועולה עליהם תקוני נפשות הצדיקים המתים

In the Garden of Eden, which is above the sun, His goodness is renewed every day, for "the Lord God is a sun and shield"[A] (Psalm 84:11) in His own realm, not in the realm of ordinary mortals. And all of this occurs through the mystical process of spiritual awakening that rises from the souls of the living, and upon them ascend the rectifications of the souls of

[A] Or: "a sun and shield is the LORD God" — This alternative maintains the exact word order of the Hebrew biblical quote, which might be preferred for scholarly precision, though the meaning remains the same.

[1] The author refers to the kabbalistic structure of the soul, where ruach (spirit) and neshamah (higher soul) represent progressively higher levels of soul consciousness. Each level dwells in a corresponding spiritual realm after death.

[2] These terms (merkavot, tikkunim, and kishutim) are technical kabbalistic concepts referring to the spiritual vehicles, corrections, and embellishments that souls create through their devotional practices and that accompany them in the afterlife.

[i] The author makes a logical argument from lesser to greater: if ordinary prayer has such cosmic power, how much more powerful must be the unifications performed by souls in the Garden of Eden after death, where they operate at higher spiritual levels (ruach and neshamah) than during physical life.

[ii] Cf. Ecclesiastes 9:10 — The author uses this verse from Ecclesiastes as a starting point to develop his argument that while the wicked cannot perform spiritual work after death, the righteous continue their spiritual development in the afterlife. He reinterprets the verse to apply only to the wicked, not to the righteous. | Cf. Psalm 115:17 — This verse is cited to support the author's argument that the wicked cannot repent after death. The 'silence' refers to the state of those who did not prepare themselves spiritually during life. | Cf. Idra Ha'azinu — The author refers to a section of the Zohar known as Idra Ha'azinu, which contains mystical teachings. This reference establishes the kabbalistic framework for his interpretation. | Cf. Deuteronomy 29:28 — The author reinterprets this biblical verse to suggest that while the plain meaning of Torah is accessible in this world, the mystical meanings will be revealed to the righteous in the World to Come. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The author cites the Zohar's section on Vayakhel to support his claim about the power of intention to sanctify the body and draw divine light. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — These references to sections of the Zohar support the author's description of how prayers ascend through the heavenly realms and are unified by the angel Sandalphon.

[iii] This phrase 'above the sun' establishes the Garden of Eden as a transcendent realm beyond the physical cosmos, not subject to the natural laws of our material universe.

[iv] This Aramaic phrase distinguishes between God's realm (the divine domain) and the mundane realm of ordinary humans, emphasizing the ontological gap between these two domains of existence.

[v] The term 'התעוררות' (awakening/arousal) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to spiritual activities that create metaphysical effects across different realms. Here it specifically refers to how actions of living souls generate spiritual energy that ascends to higher worlds.

בנזכר:[vi] the righteous dead,[1] as mentioned.[2]

פרק ל״ב

Chapter 32

הנה דבר מוכרח מעצמו שבעת יציאת הצדיק מן העולם מלאכי השרת יוצאים לקראתו ואחר זה ייפו כחו למעלה[i] יען כי נהנו מתורתו שעסק בעה״ז כאשר כתב ר״מ דף קפ״א וז״ל ואפי׳ מלאכין לית לון מזונא אלא בצדיקים דאי לאו בצדיקים יתעסקון באורייתא לא הוה נחית לון מזונא מסטרא דאורייתא דאימתילא לעץ הה״ד עץ חיים היא למחזיקים בה[ii] ולאיבא דאיהי מצוה וה״נ אורייתא אמתילא למיא וה״נ לאשא ולא נחית מיא מלעילא וכן חמה דהיא אשא לא נחית לבשלא פירות האילן אלא בגין ישראל[iii] הנה שכל המלאכים הממונים על הארץ ולדרים נהנים מהתורה והמצות ומושפעים ע״י מעשה התחתונים הזכים ומה שלמעלה

It is inherently self-evident that when a righteous person departs from this world,[3] ministering angels come forth to greet him, and afterward his spiritual power is enhanced above, because they have benefited from the Torah he studied in this world.[4] As written in Ra'aya Mehemna, page 181: "Even angels have no sustenance except through the righteous, for if the righteous did not engage in Torah study, no sustenance would descend to them [the angels] from the aspect of Torah, which is compared to a tree, as it is written, 'It is a tree of life to those who grasp it.' And to its fruit, which is the commandment. Similarly, Torah is compared to water, and likewise to fire. Water does not descend from above, and similarly the sun, which is fire, does not descend to ripen the fruits of the tree, except for the sake of Israel."[5] Thus, all the angels appointed over the earth and its inhabitants benefit from Torah and commandments, receiving divine influence through the pure deeds of those below. And those [angels] above them benefit from the power of the soul's root that illuminates

[1] The term 'rectifications' (תקונים) refers to the kabbalistic concept that souls continue their spiritual development after death, progressively repairing and elevating themselves through cosmic levels. This process is facilitated by the spiritual actions of those still living.

[2] This indicates that the author is referring back to a topic previously discussed in the work, specifically the relationship between living and deceased souls and how they mutually influence each other's spiritual development.

[3] The Hebrew opening phrase 'הנה דבר מוכרח מעצמו' suggests not merely an obvious fact but a metaphysical necessity—something that must happen according to the spiritual laws governing the cosmos.

[4] This establishes a principle of cosmic reciprocity where angels, despite their seemingly higher status, depend on human Torah study for their sustenance, inverting the expected hierarchy between heavenly and earthly beings.

[5] This theurgic concept presents the Jewish people as responsible for maintaining natural processes in the world, suggesting that even the sun's heat ripening fruit depends on Israel's spiritual service.

[vi] Cf. Psalm 84:11 — The author quotes 'the Lord God is a sun and shield' to establish that God's light and protection exist in the higher spiritual realms, unlike in the material world. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The phrase 'as mentioned' refers to earlier discussions in Ma'avar Yabok about the interaction between souls of the living and the dead, indicating this is part of a larger discourse on the afterlife.

[i] The phrase 'his power is enhanced above' refers to the soul gaining additional spiritual strength and capacity after death, contrary to the common notion that death represents a diminishment.

[ii] This quote from Proverbs 3:18 comparing Torah to the Tree of Life establishes a connection between Torah study and the primordial Tree of Life in the Garden of Eden, suggesting that proper Torah study can partially restore the spiritual state that existed before Adam's sin.

[iii] This passage articulates a theurgic view of reality where natural processes like ripening fruit depend on Israel's spiritual service, presenting the Jewish people as cosmic maintainers of creation through their religious practices.

מהם נהנים מכח שרשי הנשמה המאירה להם בכחה שעולה אליה מענפיה מלמטה ומכל
25 השפע שמשפיע באבי״ע גם הוא יקח חלק הראוי לו ויהיה ברכה.
ושם בג״ע יהיה השפע רבה מכ״ש ממה דהוה בעה״ז והדרוש הלז מתרחב מעצמו לאין תכלית
30 למעיין ומבין בו. ועיין בבכורות פרק פסולי המוקדשין על פסוק אגורה באהלך עולמים. ולא
זו בלבד הנה הצדיקים שבג״ע בכל יום ויום כחם מתגבר
35 עליהם בתוספת אור בחדוה רבה ביחודא דקב״ה ושכינתיה ובגין דאינון קריבין למלכא תדיר פורעים בכל יום למלכא עסקיה דמטרוניתה שחולת
40 אה״בה רבה היא דאינון נגידו דתליסר נהרי דאפרסמונא דכיא במספר אהב״ה. וכתב הגאון מורי מפאנו זצ״ל במ׳ חקור דין ח״א פ׳ כ״ה כי העבודה שבגן
45 היא קיום התורה מעוני ושמירה שבעדן היא קיומה מעושר[i] ומזה נדין לאדם המך כי העבודה הוא בעה״ז ושמירה הוא בעולם הנשמות ולעתיד לבא יתקיים
50 עבודה ושמירה בגוף ונפש יחד במדרגה רמה ממה שהוא עתה בעולם הנשמות ונעבדה לשמרה היא לשכינה או לנשמה וזהו ומשחרי ימצאוני המתקנים
55 בעה״ז נהורא שחרא דא זכו לעה״ב לנהורא חיורא דנהרא. ובזה נבין אמרם כי התורה היתה כתובה אש שחורה על גבי אש לבנה בסוד אספקלריא שאינה

them through its strength, which rises to it from its branches below. And from all the divine flow that emanates throughout the worlds of Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah, he [the righteous person] also takes his deserved portion and becomes a blessing. 25R

And there in the Garden of Eden, the divine flow will be even more abundant than what existed in this world.[1] This subject expands infinitely of its own accord for one who contemplates and understands it. See also Tractate Bekhorot, chapter "Disqualified Consecrated Items," regarding the verse "May I dwell in Your tent forever." 30R

Moreover, the righteous in the Garden of Eden experience their power intensifying daily with additional light, in great joy, through the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence. Because they are constantly close to the King, they settle the King's business with the Queen daily, for she is "sick with great love," referring to the flow of thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil,[2] corresponding to the numerical value of "love" (אהב״ה). 35R 40R

My teacher, the Gaon of Fano, of blessed memory, wrote in Ma'amar Chikur Din, Part 1, Chapter 25, that "working" in the Garden refers to fulfilling Torah in poverty, while "guarding" in Eden refers to fulfilling it in wealth. From this we can derive for the humble person that "working" pertains to this world, while "guarding" pertains to the world of souls. In the future time, both working and guarding will be fulfilled together in body and soul, at a higher level than currently exists in the world of souls. "To work it and to guard it" refers to the Divine Presence or to the soul. This is the meaning of "Those who seek me diligently will find me"—those who rectify the black light in this world merit the radiating white light in the World to Come.[3] 45R 50R 55R

Through this we can understand their statement that the Torah was written as black fire upon white

[1] The Hebrew term 'שפע רבה' refers to divine emanation or influx, a key concept in Kabbalah indicating how divine energy flows downward through spiritual worlds to sustain creation.

[2] This image of balsam rivers appears frequently in rabbinic literature to describe rewards in the World to Come. The number thirteen corresponds to divine attributes of mercy and is equated here with the numerical value of the Hebrew word for 'love' (אהבה).

[3] The contrast between 'black light' (נהורא שחרא) and 'white light' (נהורא חיורא) represents the difference between Torah understood in this world versus its full illumination in the World to Come.

[i] This interpretation of Genesis 2:15 ('to work it and guard it') transforms the simple meaning about gardening into a mystical reference to different ways of fulfilling Torah: through poverty in this world and through spiritual wealth in the afterlife.

מאירה ובמאירה[i] וזו סלם לזו
ואמרו תלמידיו לרבי שמעון
בן יוחאי בפ׳ תרומה על פסוק
כן בקדש חזיתיך דהוו עתידין
למשתי בצחותא מליה בבי
מקדשא עילאה אתר דאקרי קדש
כדהוו עבדי בעה״ז וכשנשים
לב על פסוקי מזמור אלהים
אלי אתה אשחרך מתוכו יתבאר
דרושינו זה. זאת ועוד מדי
חדש בחדשו ומדי שבת בשבתו
בעלות נשמות הצדיקים שמודים
יחד נר״ן דרך מכון הר ציון
להראות את פני המלך הקדוש
ולהשתחוות לפניו[ii] שההשתחויה
רומזת הורדת שפע ובכחם זה
מתעדנים שם בצרורא דחיי כמה
וכמה רבו יתירא מתוסף להון
כי באור פני מלך חיים ומכמה
נהורין ועטרין עילאין מתזנין
ומתהנין תמן. והנה משה רבינו
ע״ה בגוף ונפש בעלותו אל ה׳
בפעם אחת זכה לקרני ההוד
ומזה נבין שכל נשמת צדיק זוכה
לקרני הוד כפי השגתו והחופה
הראוי לו באופן שהצדיקים
בחזרתן למטן למקומם בכל
פעם ופעם כחם יפה מאד להדר
ולקלס מלכא עילאה ותורתם
נאדרי בכח. וכתוב בסבא כדינא
דאבא עביד לברתיה דחביבא
לגביה דנשיק לה וגפיף לה ויהיב
לה מתנן כך קב״ה עביד לנשמתא
זכאה בכל יומא הנה שאפי׳
בכל יום בעבודתם הרוחנית
בהתעסקם בתורת אור קונין
דבקות דהיינו נשיקין דרוחא
ברוחא ברחימותא ונכללים מן

fire,[1] symbolizing the non-luminous lens and the luminous lens, one being a ladder to the other. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's disciples said to him in Parashat Terumah, regarding the verse "So have I seen You in the sanctuary," that they would drink his words with clarity in the supernal sanctuary, the place called "holy," just as they did in this world. When we reflect on the verses of the psalm "O God, You are my God, I seek You at dawn," our exposition becomes clear from within it.

Furthermore, from one New Moon to another and from one Sabbath to another, when the souls of the righteous ascend together—nefesh, ruach, and neshamah—through the site of Mount Zion to appear before the Holy King and prostrate themselves before Him (the prostration symbolizing the descent of divine influence[2]), through this power they delight there in the bond of life. How much additional greatness is added to them, for "in the light of the King's countenance is life," and they are nourished and enjoy many lights and supernal crowns there.

Indeed, Moses our Teacher, peace be upon him, in body and soul, when he ascended to God at one time, merited the rays of glory. From this we understand that every righteous soul merits rays of glory according to its attainment and the canopy appropriate for it, such that when the righteous return below to their place, each time their power is greatly enhanced to glorify and praise the Supernal King, and their Torah is magnificent in power.

It is written in Saba [an Aramaic section of the Zohar] that just as a father treats his beloved daughter—kissing her, embracing her, and giving her gifts—so does the Holy One, blessed be He, treat the meritorious soul every day. Thus, even in their daily spiritual service, as they engage in the Torah of light, they acquire cleaving, namely, kisses

[1] This Talmudic description of the Torah's appearance (Yerushalmi Shekalim 6:1) is reinterpreted here in kabbalistic terms to represent different levels of spiritual perception and illumination.

[2] This parenthetical explanation reveals the kabbalistic understanding of ritual prostration as not merely submission to God but as actively drawing divine energy downward through the spiritual worlds.

[i] These terms refer to different levels of prophetic vision, with Moses alone achieving the 'luminous lens' (clear vision) while other prophets received revelation through the 'non-luminous lens' (obscured vision). Here, they are applied to Torah study in this world versus the World to Come.

[ii] This description parallels the three biblical pilgrimage festivals where Jews would 'appear before God' at the Temple in Jerusalem, suggesting that souls continue this practice in spiritual realms after death.

אורות ימיניים ושמאליים והיינו
וגפיף לה ונתוסף להם אור ושפע
100 וברכה ועילוי מהמשביר לכל
וזהו ויהיב לה מתנן וע״ש דף
צ״ז צ״ח צ״ט מעילוי הנשמות
ואיך מתעטרן רוחי ונשמתי
וסלקי לעילא.[i] ולנשמה וגם
105 לרוח אית להו שאר כסות ועונה
ושלשה אלה אתמשכן מעלמא
דאתי ע״ש. ונשמות המתלבשים
בעלייתן בנשמות שהם תחת כנפי
השכינה לבר בשחוזרין לעלות
110 פעם אחרת מתפשטין מהן דתמן
אינם קיימין בלבושא וזהו טעם
שכל שהיה מחזיק בנכסי הגר
בנעני היה זוכה בהם[ii] אשרי עין
ראתה כל אלה ומה רב טובו
115 אשר צפן ליראיו. שים נא עיניך
וקרא כל תקון נ׳ כי שם ביאר
כמה מיני יחודים ופרנסות דאית
לה לקדושה בגלות והכל הוא
כפי מעשה התחתונים ומתפרנסת
120 באורות המעלים לה[iii] אשרי
השם בקרבו את רוח קדשו
ומוצא מקום לה׳ כי ממקומו יפן
ברחמיו לעמו ברוך שמו המהולל
ברוב התושבחות. וזה כלל גדול
125 לכל מעשי בני אדם לכוין באלו
הוא עובד בג״ע לפני השכינה
שנשמתו שם פועלת ועושה[iv] כמו
שפועל גופו למטה בכוונה

of spirit with spirit in love, and they are included in lights from the right and the left—this is the meaning of "embracing her." And light, divine flow, 100R
blessing, and elevation are added to them from the Provider of all—this is the meaning of "giving her gifts." See there, pages 97, 98, and 99, regarding the elevation of souls and how spirits and souls are crowned and ascend above. 105R

For the neshamah and also for the ruach, there exists food, clothing, and conjugal right[1]s, and these three extend from the World to Come. See there. And souls that are clothed during their ascent in other souls that are beneath the wings of the Di- 110R
vine Presence externally, when they return to ascend again, divest themselves of these [garments], for there they do not remain in garments. This is the reason why one who took possession of a gentile convert's property would acquire it.[2] Happy is the eye that has 115R
seen all these things,[3] and how great is His goodness that He has stored up for those who fear Him.

Please set your eyes and read all of Tikkun 50, for there he explained many types of unifications and sustenance that exist for holiness in exile, all accord- 120R
ing to the deeds of those below. It is sustained by the lights that elevate it. Fortunate is one who places within himself the spirit of His holiness and finds a place for God, for from His place He will turn in mercy to His people. Blessed is His Name, which is 125R
praised with abundant praises.

This is a great principle for all human actions: to direct one's intention as if working in the Gar-

[1]These three terms (שאר כסות ועונה) come from Exodus 21:10 describing a husband's obligations to his wife, but are reinterpreted here to describe how spiritual souls are sustained in the afterlife.
[2]This refers to a Talmudic law (Kiddushin 17b) about ownerless property of a deceased convert, which the author interprets mystically as parallel to how souls divest garments when entering higher realms.
[3]This expression of wonder at divine mysteries is typical of kabbalistic texts, suggesting that the author has personally experienced or witnessed these spiritual realities through mystical contemplation.

[i]The author refers readers to specific pages in the Zohar that contain more detailed explanations about how souls are elevated and crowned after death, indicating that this passage is an abbreviated summary of more extensive teachings.
[ii]This curious connection between a halakhic principle (property of a deceased convert without heirs is ownerless) and mystical soul processes suggests that legal concepts in Judaism often have esoteric correspondences in kabbalistic thought.
[iii]This phrase encapsulates a fundamental principle of kabbalistic thought: that divine emanations and spiritual realities are sustained and influenced by human religious actions below.
[iv]This instruction to visualize oneself serving in the Garden of Eden reflects a meditative technique where one imagines the higher spiritual dimension where one's soul operates while performing physical rituals.

טובה וזו הכנה למה שעתידה
130 לעשות אחר מות הגוף כנזכר
וזה לשון ר״ש בן יוחאי עצמו
בפ׳ חקת דף קפ״ד תא חזי כל
מאן דידע לסדרא עובדא כדקא
יאות ולסדרא מלין כדקא יאות
135 האי האי ודאי מתערי לקוב״ה
לאמשכא מלין עילאין לגבייהו.
אי הכי כל עלמא ידעי לסדרא
טובדא ולסדרא מלין מאן חשיבו
דילהון דצדיקייא דידעי עקרא
140 דמנה ועובדא וידעי לכוונא
לבא ורעותא[i] יתיר מאלין
אחרנין דלא ידעי כל כך. וע״ש
התירוץ. הנה כי פשטי המצות עם
הכוונה טובה מתעוררים למעלה
145 ומתקדשים בקדושה העליונה
וזהו קדושים תהיו פירוש אתם
מוכנים לקבל הקדושות יען כי
קדוש אני ה׳ אלהיכם החפץ
ויכול ומטוביה מוטיב לעמיה
150 בריך שמיה לעד: [ii]

den of Eden before the Divine Presence, for one's soul operates and acts there just as one's body acts below with good intention. This is preparation for what it will do after the death of the body, as mentioned. And these are the words of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai himself in Parashat Chukat, page 184: "Come and see, whoever knows how to arrange an action properly and to arrange words properly, this person certainly awakens the Holy One, blessed be He, to draw down supernal matters to them. If so, the whole world knows how to arrange actions and words[1]—what then is the distinction of the righteous? They know the root of the matter and the action, and they know how to direct their heart and will more than these others who do not know as much." See there for the answer. 130R 135R 140R

Thus, the plain meanings of the commandments, with proper intention, awaken [forces] above and are sanctified in supernal holiness. This is the meaning of "You shall be holy"—you are prepared to receive holiness because "I, the Lord your God, am holy"—He who desires and is able, and from His goodness benefits His people. Blessed be His Name forever. 145R 150R

פרק ל״ג

Chapter 33

עלה במחשבתי ללקט מבחר

It occurred to me to gather selected words of the

[1] Rabbi Shimon's question highlights the paradox that while everyone performs the same mitzvot and prayers (actions and words), only the righteous achieve profound cosmic effects, leading to his explanation about the crucial role of intention.

[i] The distinction between ordinary people and the righteous lies in three elements: knowing the root principle behind commandments, knowing the proper action, and being able to direct the heart and will with greater intensity and precision.

[ii] Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — The author cites this text to establish the cosmic significance of Torah study, showing that the righteous person's spiritual activities in this world directly nourish and sustain celestial beings. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage builds on previous sections of Ma'avar Yabok that explained the soul's departure, now focusing specifically on how the righteous soul is greeted by angels and receives enhanced power in the afterlife. | Cf. Ma'amar Chikur Din by Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano — The author cites his teacher's work to establish a kabbalistic interpretation of Genesis 2:15 ('to work it and guard it'), connecting these actions to different spiritual realms and conditions. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This reference illustrates how the study of mystical teachings in this world creates a parallel experience in higher spiritual realms after death. | Cf. Tractate Bekhorot — The author points to this Talmudic discussion as further evidence for his claims about the righteous dwelling in divine realms after death. | Cf. Zohar, Saba (The Elder) — This zoharic passage is cited to illustrate the intimate relationship between God and the souls of the righteous in the Garden of Eden, emphasizing the ongoing nature of divine rewards. | Cf. Tikkun 50 — The author directs readers to this section of Tikkunei Zohar for deeper understanding of how divine energies are sustained through human actions. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Chukat — This quotation establishes the superiority of the righteous in properly directing intention, explaining why their actions have greater cosmic impact.

דברי חכמים ולסדר איזה
פרקים בלשון מובן לכל תלמיד
קטן אשר עלימו תטוף מלתי
בדרושי ג״ע[i] ואגב יבא ג״כ
קצת ממה שמצאתי זעיר הנה
זעיר הנה שדברו חכמים במהות
הגיהנם[ii] יען כי אחד מכוונתי
בחבורי זה מלבד הנוגע לעניין
מעשה הוא ג״כ לחבר דרושים
ופרקים נאותים להלהיב לב
עובדי ה׳ שבצדקתם יחזקו ולא
ירפו ממנה בהכיר מהות נפשם
כמה רבה היא וכוונות כוללות
בעבודה ושכר הצדיקים ועלוים
אחר כמות שהם החיים הנצחיים.
זאת ועוד הרוה פרקים ודרושים
הצעתי להקרא לפני חולה
בחליו עד שלא יכבד ראשו
ואבריו עליו ויהיה שפוי לשמוע
וליקח מוסר למען ישוב אל ה׳
וירחמהו וירפאהו או יכוננהו
עליון. בפסוק והתהלכתי
בתוככם ולא תגעל נפשי אתכם
נזכר בתורה שכר ג״ע וענג
עה״ב[iii] ליודעי בינה[iv] ודברי
הנביאים והכתובים בזה רבו
מספר:[v]

Sages and to arrange certain chapters in language comprehensible to every young student, upon whom my discourse on the Garden of Eden shall flow. Incidentally, I will also include some of what I have found here and there where the Sages spoke about the nature of Gehenna. For one of my intentions in this composition, besides addressing practical matters, is also to compose discourses and appropriate chapters to inflame the hearts of those who serve God,[A] that they might strengthen their righteousness and not weaken from it by recognizing the nature of their souls—how great they are—and the comprehensive intentions in divine service and the reward of the righteous and their elevation after death, which is eternal life. Furthermore, I have proposed chapters and discourses to be read before the sick person during their illness,[1] before their head and limbs become heavy upon them,[B] while they are still lucid enough to hear and take instruction,[C] so that they may return to God who will have mercy on them and heal them, or establish them on high. In the verse "I will walk among you, and My soul shall not abhor you" (Leviticus 26:11-12), the Torah alludes to the reward of the Garden of Eden and the delight of the World to Come for those who understand, and the words of the Prophets and Writings on this subject are too numerous to count.[2]

[A] Or: "to ignite fervor in those who worship God" — This alternate translation captures the sense of spiritual enthusiasm and devotion more directly, using 'ignite fervor' as a slightly more contemporary expression of the same concept.

[B] Or: "before the illness weighs heavily on their head and limbs" — This alternative makes more explicit that the heaviness refers to the effects of illness, which is implied but not stated directly in the original.

[C] Or: "while they are still clear-minded enough to hear and receive moral guidance" — This alternate more explicitly translates 'musar' as moral guidance rather than general instruction, which better reflects its specific meaning in Jewish ethical literature.

[1] This indicates a practical purpose of Ma'avar Yabok: providing readings specifically designed for the bedside of ill people, to be read while they are still capable of understanding, suggesting this text was intended partly as a manual for those caring for the sick.

[2] The author is suggesting that while the Torah's references to afterlife rewards might be subtle

[i] This is an abbreviation for "Gan Eden" (Garden of Eden), the paradisiacal afterlife destination for the righteous in Jewish tradition.

[ii] Gehenna, the Jewish concept of a place of spiritual purification or punishment after death, often translated as "Hell" though with significant theological differences from the Christian concept.

[iii] This abbreviation stands for "Olam HaBa" (the World to Come), referring to the future perfected world or afterlife state in Jewish eschatology.

[iv] The author claims that the Torah alludes to afterlife rewards, though traditional Jewish interpretation generally sees the Torah as focusing on this-worldly consequences rather than explicit afterlife rewards. This represents a mystical reading influenced by kabbalistic tradition.

[v] Cf. Leviticus 26:11-12 — The author interprets this verse as alluding to spiritual rewards in the afterlife, specifically the Garden of Eden and the World to Come, suggesting that God's

מצאתי כתוב בספרים קדמונים
ובספר אסף ההודי[i] כי יושבי
הארץ הזאת רואים עץ הדעת
טוב ורע ועץ החיים שבתוך הגן
ורואים להט החרב המתהפכת
ושם יש כרובים שהם מלאכי דין
שתופסין נשמת האדם בצאתו
מן העולם ומקדמת לפתח ג״ע
ופניהם פני כרוב ודנים אותה
והם מחיצה המבדלת בין קדושי
הגן אל החיצונים[ii] ושכינה
דנה שם הנשמה אם אינה זוכה
הכרובים מוסרים אותה אל
להט מלאכי חבלה יובילוה
לגיהנם ולהיות כי מתהפכים
לאדם פעמים לפתותו ואח״כ
להלשינו ואח״כ לאויבים לדונו
על דרך הוא שמן הוא יצר הרע
הוא מלאך המות[iii] לכן נקראת
מתהפכת ומתפשטים מהחרב
שהיא מלכות המתהפכת בפי
מה שאדם מהפך אותה אם לדין
ח״ו ואם לרחמים ודין גיהנם
אינו רק כפי גזרת דין שמים כי
אין יכולים להוסיף אפי׳ כמלא
נימא והיינו גם כי אלך בגיא
צלמות לא אירע רע כי אתה
עמדי כפי גזרת מדת המלכות
והיינו ואציעה שאול הנך. הנה
הם להט מהחרב המתהפכת

I found written in ancient books and in the book of Asaf the Indian that the inhabitants of this land see the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil and the Tree of Life that are in the midst of the garden, and they see the flame of the revolving sword. There are cherubim there who are angels of judgment that seize the soul of man when it departs from the world and bring it to the entrance of the Garden of Eden. Their faces are the faces of cherubim, and they judge it. They form a partition that separates the holy ones of the garden from the external forces. The Divine Presence judges the soul there;[1] if it is not found worthy, the cherubim deliver it to the flame of the angels of destruction who lead it to Gehenna.

These angels transform in relation to man: sometimes to tempt him, then to accuse him, and finally to become adversaries who judge him—following the pattern that Satan, the evil inclination, and the Angel of Death are one and the same. Therefore, it is called "revolving," and these extend from the sword, which is the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom) that transforms according to how man transforms it[2]—whether to judgment, God forbid, or to mercy.

The judgment of Gehenna is only according to the decree of heavenly judgment, for they cannot add even so much as a hairsbreadth to it. This is the meaning of "Though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You are with me"—according to the decree of the attribute of Malkhut. And this is also the meaning of "If I make

and require interpretation, the later biblical books (Prophets and Writings) contain more explicit references to these concepts.

[1]The term 'Shekhinah' (Divine Presence) in kabbalistic thought often represents the feminine aspect of divinity, associated with the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom) mentioned later in the text. This creates a conceptual link between the Divine Presence that judges souls and the 'sword' that is identified with Malkhut.

[2]This reflects a fundamental kabbalistic principle that human actions affect the divine realms. The text suggests that human behavior determines whether divine judgment manifests as severity or mercy.

presence among the people is a foretaste of the ultimate spiritual union after death | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's organization — This passage reveals that Ma'avar Yabok has a dual purpose: to inspire the living to strengthen their religious observance through understanding the soul's nature and eternal rewards, and to provide practical guidance for those ministering to the sick and dying

[i]Asaf the Indian (or Asaf the Physician) was a legendary Jewish physician and herbalist to whom several medical and wisdom texts were attributed in medieval Jewish tradition. The reference here suggests the author is drawing on a work attributed to this figure.

[ii]The concept of a partition (mechitzah) separating holy entities from unholy ones is a recurring theme in Jewish mysticism. Here it refers to the cherubim forming a boundary between the sanctity of Eden and the 'external forces' (hachitzonim), a kabbalistic term for negative spiritual entities.

[iii]This is a direct reference to a Talmudic teaching (Bava Batra 16a) that Satan, the evil inclination, and the Angel of Death are one and the same entity fulfilling different functions.

ובזה נמצא כי דין גיהנם הוא
יצה״ר הוא מלאך המות כי שכר
עבירה עבירה.[i] וצריך להזדכך
דרך אלו קודם שיכנס אל הגן
ומשם אל עץ החיים לאכול
מפריו ולחיות לעולם. וחכמי
הקדמונים שהיה אסקלפייגוס
חכם מקדוני[ii] וארבעים איש
מלומדי החכמה ידעו המקום
הזה וראו ארבע נהרות יוצאים
משם והתחילו להלוך דרך פרת
למעלה וכשהגיעו חצי מיל
לפני הגן להט אותם להט החרב
המתהפכת ונשרפו וכתב בעל
צדה לדרך בסוף ספרו [iii]

my bed in Sheol, behold, You are there." These are the flame of the revolving sword. 60R

Thus, we find that the judgment of Gehenna, the evil inclination, and the Angel of Death are one,[1] for "the reward of sin is sin." One must be purified through these before entering the garden[2] and from there to the Tree of Life to eat of its fruit and live forever. 65R

The ancient sages—among them Aesculapius, a Macedonian sage, and forty men learned in wisdom—knew this place and saw four rivers flowing from it. They began to travel up along the Euphrates, but when they reached half a mile before the garden, the flame of the revolving sword burned them.[3] And the author of Tzeidah la-Derekh wrote at the end of his book... 70R

רבים מהבאים ארצה בני
קדם רואים מרחוק להט

Many of those who come to the land of the East see from afar the flame of the revolving sword.[4] Many 75R

[1]The text establishes a unity between the afterlife punishment (Gehenna), the psychological force that tempts people to sin (evil inclination), and the metaphysical agent of death (Angel of Death). This unification suggests that these are all manifestations of the same cosmic principle of judgment and consequence.

[2]This introduces the concept that the soul's journey through judgment and potential punishment is ultimately purificatory rather than purely punitive, allowing the soul to eventually reach higher spiritual realms (the Garden and the Tree of Life).

[3]This anecdote about non-Jewish sages attempting to physically reach the Garden of Eden serves to emphasize that the Garden exists both as a physical and metaphysical reality, but can only be properly approached through spiritual means rather than physical exploration.

[4]This biblical image from Genesis 3:24 (the flaming sword guarding the Garden of Eden) is being reinterpreted as a mystical barrier that prevented Greek philosophers from accessing divine truth. The author presents a legend that suggests forty Greek philosophers were burned by this flame when attempting to approach paradise.

[i]This is a reference to the mishnaic teaching in Pirkei Avot 4:2: 'Ben Azzai said: Run to perform even a minor mitzvah and flee from sin, for one mitzvah leads to another mitzvah, and one sin leads to another sin...'

[ii]This appears to be a reference to Asclepius, the Greek god of medicine and healing, here transformed into a Macedonian sage. This reflects the medieval Jewish tendency to historicize mythological figures and incorporate elements of Greek wisdom traditions into their cosmological frameworks.

[iii]Cf. Genesis 3:24 — The author builds his entire mystical framework around this biblical passage, expanding on the role of the cherubim and flaming sword as agents of divine judgment who determine the soul's fate after death. | Cf. Zohar — The author is clearly drawing on Zoharic concepts about how souls are judged after death, particularly the idea that the same forces that tempt a person in life become their accusers and judges after death. | Cf. Talmud Bava Batra 16a — The author directly quotes this Talmudic teaching to support his explanation of how the same spiritual entities fulfill different functions in relation to human souls. | Cf. Psalms 23:4 — The author interprets this verse as evidence that divine judgment in the afterlife is precisely measured and limited according to heavenly decree. | Cf. Psalms 139:8 — The author uses this verse to reinforce that even in the realm of punishment (Sheol/Gehenna), divine presence limits and controls the judgment process. | Cf. Pirkei Avot 4:2 — The author applies this principle to explain that the punishment of Gehenna is a natural consequence of sin rather than an arbitrary punishment.

החרב המתהפכת ואמרו הרבה
מהחכמים כי אז נאבדו חכמות
יונים הקדמונים בשריפת
הארבעים אלו שהם היו קרובים
80 אל האמת ושומעים ולומדים
חכמת חכמי תורתנו. ובתוב
בספר תורת העולה חלק א׳ פרק
י״א כי אפלטון קבל החכמה מן
הנביאים וסקרט קבל מאחיתופל
85 ומאסף הקרחי. ואח״כ באו
האחרונים ארסט״ו וחביריו
ולקחו החכמה באומד הדעת
ואין לה צד ענין בתורתנו ואם
נמצאו בדבריו דבר טוב כתוב
90 בשבילי אמונה שגנב אותם
מחכמת שלמה כי אלכסנדרו״ס
מוקדון השליט רבו הנזכר על
אוצר ספרי שלמה וכל דבר
טוב שמצא בהם כתבם בשמו
95 וערב בהם דעות רעות וזרות
בקדמות העולם וכיוצא וא״כ
אפי׳ יהיה האדם חכם כדניאל
או כיהושע בן נון אל יסמוך על
חקירותיו לפי שכלו וחכמתו
100 כי מי לנו גדול כאבינו הראשון
שהיה איכותו עד לשמים ובטח
בשכלו בנזכר וקצץ בנטיעות
והפריד אלוף ח״ו. נח רצה
לעלות מתוך היכל החיצונים
105 לקדושה ונאחז בהם כי אחז ביין
המשכר ונפגע. נדב ואביהוא

sages have said that it was then that the wisdom of the ancient Greeks was lost in the burning of those forty [sages], who had been close to the truth and who had listened to and learned from the wisdom of 80R
our Torah scholars. It is written in the book Torat Ha-Olah, Part 1, Chapter 11, that Plato received wisdom from the prophets, and Socrates received from Ahitophel and Asaph the Korahite.[1] Later came the later ones, Aristotle and his colleagues, 85R
who took wisdom through estimation of their own intellect, and it has no connection to our Torah. And if good things are found in his words, it is written in Shvilei Emunah that he stole them from the wisdom of Solomon,[2] for Alexander of Macedon gave his 90R
aforementioned teacher control over Solomon's treasury of books, and every good thing he found in them, he wrote in his own name, mixing in evil and strange opinions such as the eternity of the world and the like. Thus, even if a person were as wise 95R
as Daniel or like Joshua son of Nun, he should not rely on his investigations according to his intellect and wisdom, for who is greater than our first father [Adam], whose quality reached the heavens, yet he trusted in his intellect, as mentioned, and 100R
"cut the plantings" and separated the Chief, God forbid.[A] Noah wanted to ascend from the palace of the external forces[B] to holiness, but he was caught by them when he grasped the intoxicating wine and was harmed. Nadab and Abihu materialized [God] 105R
and gazed [improperly] and died,[C] and this is [the meaning of] "who has ascended to heaven through

[A] Or: "and cut down the saplings and separated the Aluf (Chief/Master), Heaven forbid" — This is a kabbalistic reference to Adam's sin that damaged the divine unity. 'Cutting the plantings' (kitzetz ba-netiot) is a technical term in Jewish mysticism for heresy that separates divine attributes. The alternate translation preserves the technical nature while also maintaining the metaphorical imagery of cutting plants.

[B] Or: "palace of the external realms" — In Kabbalistic terminology, 'chitzonim' (external ones) refers to the demonic realms or forces of impurity. This alternate provides a slightly more neutral rendering while still conveying the mystical context.

[C] Or: "corporealized [the Divine] and peered [at what was forbidden] and died" — This refers to the sin of Nadab and Abihu who approached the Divine inappropriately. 'Higshimu' literally means 'they made physical' and refers to the theological error of attributing physical form to God. This alternate translation might better capture the technical theological concept involved.

[1] This reflects a medieval Jewish apologetic tradition that claimed Greek philosophy derived from Jewish sources. By asserting that Plato learned from biblical prophets and Socrates from biblical figures, the author subordinates Greek philosophy to Jewish wisdom, suggesting that any truth in Greek thought was borrowed from Jewish tradition.

[2] The author continues the polemic against Greek philosophy by claiming Aristotle plagiarized his ideas from Solomon's books. This narrative, which connects to legends about Alexander the Great's conquests, serves to portray Greek philosophy as derivative rather than original.

הגשימו והציצו ומתו וזהו
מי עלה שמים בחקירה וירד
בשלום ולכן שומר נפשו ירחק
מחכמת הפלוסופיא והחקירה
השקרית ואל ישעה בדברי שקר
בהקדמות המזוייפות אשר בדו
הפלוסופים הקדמונים מלבם
שהם ודאי מבלי עולם אויבי
השם מוקדי עולם השמים עקרי
תורתנו תלויים בעפושי שכליהם
ואותותי כזביהם אוי להם כי
נדדו ורחקו מעל ה׳. וכתב בעל
דרך חיים איש מופלא בדורו
ויראֵ את ה׳ מרבים כאשר העידו
על חסידותו וחכמתו שלמים וכן
רבים שמכל עברות אשר עברו
עליו מיום היותו עד היום שחבר
ספרו היקר עון זה שסטה אל
סטי כלב מחכמת הפלוסופיא
השקרה בילדותו הכריע את
כלם כי היא מולידה עמל ואון
בדיעות אלהיות האמיתיות.
ושפחה תירש גברתה וכל באיה
לא ישובון כי נופת תטופנה שפתי
זרה ואחריתה מרה כלענה כי
ממנה סברות ארסיות ממיתות
וחדה כחרב פיות שמנפש עד
בשר תבלה ושאול צעדיה
יתמוכו והמבלה ימיו בה ינהום
באחריתו כרשעים שמלאים
חרטות ויאמר איך שנאתי מוסר
ותוכחת נאץ לבי ולא שמעתי
בקול מורי כמעט הייתי בכל
רע בתוך קהל ועדה כי בהבל
פיהם משמיעים קול המון לעם
בפירושי פסוקים ומאמרים כפי
כזביהם והם בקול הסירים תחת
הסיר בדברים מרבים הבל וכל
רוח אין בהם. וכל זמן שמזקינים

investigation and returned in peace?"[1] Therefore, one who guards his soul should distance himself from the philosophy and false investigation and not turn to words of falsehood in the fabricated premises that the ancient philosophers invented from their hearts, for they are certainly destroyers of the world, enemies of God, kindlers of the world,[2] [who claim] the foundations of our Torah depend on the rot of their intellects and the signs of their lies. Woe to them, for they have wandered and distanced themselves from God.

The author of Derekh Chaim, an exceptional man in his generation who feared God more than many, as perfect and numerous people testified regarding his piety and wisdom, wrote that of all the sins that passed over him from the day of his existence until the day he composed his precious book, this sin of deviating like a dog to the false philosophy in his youth outweighed them all, for it gives birth to toil and iniquity in true divine ideas. And a maidservant will inherit her mistress, and all who enter it will not return, for "the lips of a strange woman drip honey, but her end is bitter as wormwood," for from it come poisonous ideas that kill, and it is sharp as a two-edged sword that consumes from soul to flesh. Sheol supports her steps, and one who wastes his days in it will roar at his end like the wicked who are full of regrets, saying, "How I hated instruction, and my heart despised reproof! I did not listen to the voice of my teachers. I was almost in all evil in the midst of the congregation and assembly." For with the vanity of their mouths they make the voice of a multitude heard to the people in interpretations of verses and sayings according to their lies, and they are like the sound of thorns under the pot, with words multiplying vanity, and there is no spirit in them. And the older they get, the more foolish they become,[3] as the RABD wrote in his commentary on the fifth Mishnah of Sefer Yetzirah: "If the investigator strives to

[1] This is a rhetorical question implying that philosophical investigation into divine matters is dangerous and potentially fatal. The author suggests that just as Adam, Noah, and Nadab and Abihu suffered for their improper approaches to divinity, so too will those who rely on philosophical speculation.

[2] The original Hebrew uses a series of highly charged polemical terms to denounce philosophers. The author portrays them not merely as intellectually mistaken but as actively hostile to divine truth and destructive to the world order.

[3] This contrasts with the traditional Jewish view that wisdom increases with age. The author suggests that philosophical inquiry actually leads to intellectual deterioration rather than growth, citing the RABD (Rabbi Abraham ben David) to support this claim.

מטפשים כאשר כתב הראב״ד
בפי׳ משנה ה׳ מספר יצירה אם
יתאמץ החוקר לחקור על מה
שאין בדעתו יכולת להשיג אל
150 יעלה על דעתו שלא יוכל על
הנמנע לבד אלא אף מה שהיה
בכחו מטרם לכן להשיגו יחלש
ולא יוכל עליו ונשא משל על זה
יעויין שם. צאו נא וראו גדול
155 הפוסקים הרמב״ם ז״ל כמה
הפליג לדבר מרעות הפלוסופיא
[i]

investigate what his mind does not have the ability to grasp, let him not think that he will be unable to grasp only the impossible, but even what was previously within his power to grasp will weaken, and 150R
he will not be able to grasp it." And he offered a parable for this, which can be examined there. Go out and see the great decisor, the Rambam of blessed memory,[1] how much he went to extremes to speak of the evils of philosophy. 155R

בפרק חלק בפירוש המשנה
בביאורו מהכת השנייה אך
160 אחר שנמשך אחריה גם הוא לא

In his commentary on the Mishnah, chapter Helek,[2] explaining the second group [of heretics], even though he himself was drawn after it [philoso-

[1]The invocation of Maimonides (Rambam) as an opponent of philosophy is somewhat ironic, given his significant engagement with Aristotelian philosophy. The author likely refers to Maimonides' warnings about the limits of philosophical speculation in certain theological matters, selectively emphasizing aspects of his thought that align with the anti-philosophical polemic.

[2]This refers to the tenth chapter of Tractate Sanhedrin in the Mishnah, which begins with the words 'All Israel has a portion in the World to Come' and discusses those who forfeit this portion.

[i]Cf. Torat Ha-Olah — The author cites Rabbi Moses Isserles' work Torat Ha-Olah as a source for the claim that Plato and Socrates received their wisdom from Jewish sources. This reference supports the author's argument against Greek philosophy by suggesting that whatever truth it contained was actually derived from Jewish wisdom. | Cf. Shvilei Emunah — The author references this work to support the claim that Aristotle stole his knowledge from Solomon's books. This strengthens the case against Greek philosophy by portraying Aristotle as a plagiarist rather than an original thinker. | Cf. Rambam (Maimonides) — The author invokes Maimonides as having spoken against philosophy, which is somewhat ironic given Maimonides' own deep engagement with Aristotelian philosophy. This reference likely points to Maimonides' warnings about philosophical speculation in certain theological matters, selectively citing him as an authority figure who cautioned against philosophical excess. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The citation from RABD's (Raavad's) commentary on Sefer Yetzirah warns that attempting to investigate matters beyond one's intellectual capacity can actually diminish one's existing understanding. This supports the author's overall argument against philosophical speculation into divine matters. | Cf. Derekh Chaim — The author cites this work extensively to illustrate the spiritual dangers of philosophical inquiry, portraying it as a seductive path that leads one away from true divine wisdom and ultimately to spiritual destruction. The reference serves as a cautionary tale against being led astray by Greek philosophical thinking. | Cf. Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden — The text alludes to Adam's sin as a cautionary example of relying on one's own intellect rather than divine guidance. The kabbalistic phrase 'cutting the plantings' (kitzetz ba-netiot) refers to the heretical separation of divine attributes, suggesting that philosophical speculation can lead to theological error just as Adam's actions led to cosmic damage. | Cf. Noah's intoxication — The reference to Noah becoming intoxicated (Genesis 9:20-27) is presented as an example of someone attempting to reach spiritual heights through inappropriate means and suffering negative consequences. This parallels the author's warning about the dangers of philosophical speculation. | Cf. Nadab and Abihu's death — The reference to Nadab and Abihu, who died when offering 'strange fire' before God (Leviticus 10:1-2), serves as another biblical example of the dangers of approaching divine matters improperly. In this context, they are presented as having inappropriately attempted to perceive the divine, resulting in their deaths. | Cf. Proverbs 5:3-5 — The passage alludes to Proverbs 5:3-5, which warns about the seductive nature of the 'strange woman' whose lips drip honey but whose end is bitter as wormwood. The author applies this metaphor to philosophy, suggesting it initially seems sweet and appealing but ultimately leads to spiritual destruction.

ניצול ממנה גם שברוב הדברים
קליפתה זרק. ולהיות שאין
הקב״ה מביא תקלה אפי׳ ע״י
בהמתן של צדיקים כ״ש שרגלי
חסידיו ישמור כהרב רבינו
הגדול הרמב״ם ז״ל מי כמוהו
מורה. ע״כ בסוף ימיו אורו
עיניו ותהה מהרבה מדבריו
שכתב בספר המורה וכדומה לו
שכך כתב לבנו כי זקן אחד האיר
עיניו ולולי שנתפשטו ספריו
ברוב העולם היה חוזר בו מכמה
דברים שכתב. הנה חכמה נכריה
זו אש היא עד אבדון תאכל.
שפתים ישק משיב דברים נכוחים
ה״ה הר״ר עובדיה מברטנורה
אמר כי הקורא בספרים החצונים
(דברי הכחשה בהשגחת הבורא)
שאמרו שאין לו חלק לעולם הבא
הוא הקריאה בספרי ארסט״ו
וחביריו. ובר״מ פ׳ כי תצא
דמה הפלוסופים לשדים. ברוך
טעמו של החבר כי בדברו עם
המלך כוזרי האריך הרבה בסוף
דבריו בגנות החכמה הזאת עד
כי האחרונים כתבו בספריהם
שקודם שיסטה אדם לבו לעסוק
בחכמה זרה הלזו יקרא וישנה
דברי החבר בזה ובפרט חלק
ד׳ מהכוזרי ויהיו לטוטפות
בין עיניו ומתוך דבריו נראה
גודל יקר חכמתו בכל מדע והיה
מדיני בטבע ועכ״ז געלה נפשו

phy] and did not escape it, although in most matters he discarded its shell [negative aspects]. Since the 160R
Holy One, blessed be He, does not bring about a stumbling block even through the animals of the righteous, how much more so does He guard the feet of His pious ones, like our great teacher Rabbi Moses Maimonides of blessed memory—who is like 165R
him as a teacher? Therefore, at the end of his life, his eyes were enlightened, and he regretted many of his statements that he wrote in the Guide for the Perplexed and similar works. Thus he wrote to his son that an elderly man had enlightened him,[A] and 170R
had his books not already spread throughout most of the world, he would have retracted many things he had written.[B] Indeed, this foreign wisdom is a fire that devours to destruction.[C]

Lips shall be kissed by one who returns upright 175R
words—namely Rabbi Obadiah of Bartenura, who said that what they meant by "one who reads external books (words denying divine providence) has no share in the World to Come" refers to reading the books of Aristotle and his colleagues. And in the 180R
Mishneh Torah, parashat Ki Tetze, he [Maimonides] compared philosophers to demons. Blessed is the reasoning of the author [of the Kuzari], for in his dialogue with the king of the Khazars,[1] he elaborated extensively at the end of his remarks on the disgrace 185R
of this wisdom. Later authorities even wrote in their books that before a person turns his heart to engage in this foreign wisdom, he should read and review the words of the author [Judah HaLevi] on this matter, especially part four of the Kuzari, and they should 190R
be as frontlets between his eyes.[2] From his words,

[A] Or: "Thus he wrote to his son that a certain elder had opened his eyes" — The phrase 'האיר עיניו' literally means 'illuminated his eyes' but idiomatically refers to giving someone new insight or understanding. The alternate translation 'opened his eyes' captures this metaphorical meaning and might be more natural in English.

[B] Or: "and if his books had not already been disseminated throughout most of the world, he would have recanted many things he had written" — The terms 'disseminated' and 'recanted' have a more formal, scholarly tone that might better fit the context of discussing Maimonides and his philosophical works.

[C] Or: "Behold, this alien wisdom is a fire that consumes all the way to perdition" — This alternative uses more archaic and dramatic language that might better match the rhetorical style of the original. 'Alien wisdom' emphasizes the foreign nature more strongly, and 'perdition' has religious connotations of spiritual destruction that align with the author's view of philosophy.

[1] The Kuzari is structured as a dialogue between a rabbi and the king of the Khazars, who is seeking the true religion. Written by Rabbi Judah HaLevi in the 12th century, it presents arguments for Judaism over philosophy, Christianity, and Islam.

[2] This alludes to the biblical command to wear tefillin, suggesting that Rabbi Judah HaLevi's warnings against philosophy should be kept constantly in mind, as tefillin are worn on the forehead.

בפתויי הפלוסופים כי הכיר
וידע שלמי אוי ולמי אבוי למי
שיש לו שיח ושיג בדעותיהם
הכוזבות כי ברגע תזרוק בו
טעות ומשם יפרד מקדמונו של
עולם. צאו נא וקראו מה שכתוב
בעל עבודת הקדש נגד דעותם
בהרבה מקומות ובפרט בפרקי
ט״ו ט״ז י״ז י״ח מח״ג הנקרא
חלק התכלית ובחלק העבודה
נגד תשובת בר ששת ומשם נראה
ג״כ מאין זכו לחכמה האלהית
דורות אחרונים כי רוח ה׳ דבר
בם ומלתו על לשונם. והחכם
בעל העקידה בשער ראשון דבר
תועה במוציאים ימיהם בחכמת
הפלוסופיא השקרה במשל
בנין הבית על החומר והצורה
והתכלית והפליג להזהיר האדם
ממנה בהרבה ממפתחי שעריו
ובפרט בשער ה׳ ט׳ וי״ו וגם
שהוא דורש דבריהם כבר יצא
מדי חשד בהקדמתו כי גדולה
עבירה לשמה ובשער ז׳ אמר
שחכמה זרה זו גרמה המיתה
לאדם הראשון ולכל העולם
ובעבור קנאת ה׳ צבאות נגד
העוסקים בה חבר ספר חזות
קשה בי׳ וי״ב הוכיח על פניהם
מומם והוא ודאי ידע מתי שוא
ויראו און ולא רצה להתבונן
בו. מה טובו אמריו ומה נעמו
דבר גדול הפשטנים והדרשנים
אחרונים ה״ה החכם המצויין
כמהר״ר משה אלשיך זצ״ל
בכמה מקומות הרחיק חכמה
נכריה זאת השקרה ודחה אותה
בשתי ידים בפ׳ בראשית ובשאר
מקומות מחבוריו ובפרט בפי׳
משלי הרחיק מעליה כל יראו
וחרד לעבודת ה׳. ובאמת כי
הקדמות הפלוסופים מחכמת
גלגל הירח ולמעלה מונעים
עם ה׳ מלהאמין בתורת משה
ובדברי חכמים שהם כדרבונות
וכמסמרות נטועים ומישרים

one can see the great preciousness of his wisdom in every field of knowledge, and though he was naturally political [a statesman], nevertheless his soul loathed the enticements of the philosophers, for he recognized and knew "Woe to whom and alas to whom" applies to anyone who has discourse and engagement with their false opinions, because in an instant error will be cast into him, and from there he will separate from the Ancient One of the world.[1]

Go out and read what the author of Avodat HaKodesh wrote against their opinions in many places, particularly in chapters 15, 16, 17, and 18 of part 3, called "The Section of Purpose," and in the section on worship against the response of Bar Sheshet. From there it is also evident how later generations merited divine wisdom, for the spirit of the Lord spoke through them, and His word was on their tongue. The wise author of the Akedah, in the first gate, spoke against those who spend their days in the false wisdom of philosophy, using the parable of building a house based on matter, form, and purpose, and he went to great lengths to warn people against it in many of his gateway openings, particularly in gates 5, 9, and 6. Even though he expounds their words, he has already removed himself from suspicion in his introduction, stating that "a transgression for the sake of Heaven is great." In gate 7, he said that this foreign wisdom caused death to the first man and to the entire world, and because of the zeal of the Lord of Hosts against those who engage in it, he composed the book "Hazut Kashah" in chapters 10 and 12, proving their blemish to their faces. He certainly knew when something was false and saw iniquity, and did not wish to contemplate it.

How good are his words and how pleasant is the speech of the great later literalists and homilists, namely the distinguished sage Rabbi Moses Alshich of blessed memory, who in many places distanced this false foreign wisdom and rejected it with both hands in the section of Genesis and in other places in his compositions, especially in his commentary on Proverbs, where he distanced from it everyone who fears and trembles in the service of the Lord. Indeed, the premises of the philosophers concerning the wisdom of the lunar sphere and above prevent the people

[1] This phrase refers to God as the eternal creator who precedes all existence, contrasting with philosophical concepts like Aristotle's 'unmoved mover' or the eternity of the universe.

240 האדם לעבודתו ויראתו ואהבתו של יוצרנו ב״ה. וכבר כתב אחד מן החכמים שהיה חפץ להעלות ארסט״ו [i]

of God from believing in the Torah of Moses and the words of the Sages, which are like goads and like firmly planted nails,[1] guiding a person to service, fear, and love of our Creator, blessed be He. One of the sages who wished to elevate Aristotle has already written[2] 240R

ואמר שכל מה שכתב בחכמת
245 הטבע כלו אמת. וברוך יודע האמת.[ii] ומגלגל הירח עד גלגל ערבות רובו שקר אך מה שרצה לדבר באלהיות כלו שקר וכזב. אשרי העם שה׳
250 אלהיו ולא פנה דרך שועלים המחבלים כרמים.[iii] ואמר הגאון מורי מפאנו זצ״ל כי מדרבנן בגימטריא[iv] מפי גבורה שדברי

And he said that everything he [Aristotle] wrote about natural science is entirely true. And blessed is He who knows the truth. But from the sphere of the moon to the sphere of Aravot[3] [the highest heaven], most of it is false, and what he attempted to say about divinity is entirely false and deceitful. Happy is the nation whose God is the LORD, and who has not turned to the way of foxes that destroy vineyards. And my teacher, the Gaon of Fano,[4] of blessed memory, said that the numerical value of 245R 250R

[1] This biblical metaphor from Ecclesiastes 12:11 describes the words of the wise. Here it suggests that rabbinic teachings provide firm guidance, unlike the shifting speculations of philosophy.

[2] The text appears to be cut off at this point, but seems to be transitioning to a more nuanced view that acknowledges some limited value in Aristotle's natural philosophy while rejecting his metaphysics.

[3] This cosmological description reflects the medieval Jewish understanding of the universe, derived from Aristotelian physics but modified to fit Jewish theological concepts. The 'sphere of the moon' was considered the boundary between the sublunary (changeable, imperfect) world and the celestial (unchanging, perfect) realms. 'Aravot' is the name of the seventh and highest heaven in rabbinic literature.

[4] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (c. 1548-1620), an important Italian kabbalist who synthesized the Cordoverian and Lurianic schools of Kabbalah. He is cited multiple times in Ma'avar Yabok as the author's teacher.

[i] Cf. Guide for the Perplexed (Moreh Nevuchim) — The author refers to the Guide for the Perplexed (ספר המורה) as a work that Maimonides supposedly regretted writing. This reference serves as a warning against philosophical inquiry that might lead believers away from traditional faith. | Cf. Kuzari by Judah HaLevi — The author cites the Kuzari as an authoritative source against philosophical speculation, specifically recommending part four which contains strong arguments prioritizing revelation and tradition over philosophical reasoning. This reference establishes an intellectual lineage for the anti-philosophical position. | Cf. Avodat HaKodesh by Rabbi Meir ibn Gabbai — The reference to Avodat HaKodesh strengthens the author's argument by citing another mystical work that critiques philosophical approaches to understanding God. This builds a case that true divine wisdom comes through revelation rather than reason. | Cf. Akedat Yitzchak by Rabbi Isaac Arama — The reference to Rabbi Isaac Arama's Akedat Yitzchak provides another authoritative source against philosophical inquiry. The specific mention of multiple gates (chapters) shows the author's familiarity with this work and suggests a comprehensive critique of philosophy within it. | Cf. Commentaries of Rabbi Moses Alshich — The author cites Rabbi Moses Alshich's biblical commentaries, particularly on Proverbs, as rejecting philosophical approaches. This reference adds another respected rabbinic voice to the chorus against philosophy, showing that opposition comes from both mystical and exegetical traditions.

[ii] The phrase 'And blessed is He who knows the truth' is likely an allusion to God as the ultimate arbiter of truth, suggesting a nuanced position that acknowledges some truth in Aristotle's natural philosophy while rejecting his theological views.

[iii] This is an allusion to Song of Songs 2:15, 'Catch for us the foxes, the little foxes that ruin the vineyards.' In rabbinic literature, foxes often symbolize destructive philosophical or theological ideas that undermine traditional faith.

[iv] This is a gematria equation where both phrases equal 382 in Hebrew numerology, suggesting that rabbinic teachings have divine authority equivalent to the Torah itself.

סופרים הן הם גופה של תורה.
ועיין בהערה שלנו בסוף המעירי
שחר עונש הגדול למי שאינו
עוסק בחכמת החבלה[i] בעולם
הזה ולמה נקרא חכמה מפוארה
זו קבלה:[ii]

"mi-derabbanan" [from the rabbis] equals "mi-pi gevurah" [from the mouth of Power], for the words of the Sages are the very body of the Torah. And see our note at the end of Me'irei Shachar[1] [Illuminators of Dawn] regarding the great punishment for one who does not engage in the wisdom of Kabbalah[2] in this world, and why this glorious wisdom is called "Kabbalah" [reception].

פרק ל״ד

Chapter 34

ונדעה נרדפה מדרושי גן עדן
שהיה תחלת דברינו בו בתחלת
פרק הקודם יש שכתבו כי גן עדן
תחתון הוא מהלאה לים אוקיינוס
בקו השוה אמנם דעת רשב״י
וחביריו הוא כי מקום כבודו
באמצע כל העולם בין חרבה בין
ישוב ושם יש נקודה טמונה וגנוזה
ואינה נודעת ועמוד אחד נעוץ
ממטה למעלה בתוך אותה נקודה
ומשם נובעים מים המתפרשים
לד׳ סטרי עלמא ונקודה זו
מקבלת מאימא עילאה וירושלים
היא באמצע הישוב כי בשתי

Let us know and pursue the discourses concerning the Garden of Eden,[3] which was the beginning of our discussion in the previous chapter. Some have written that the lower Garden of Eden is beyond the ocean sea at the equator.[A] However, the opinion of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his colleagues is that its place of glory is in the center of the entire world, between wasteland and settlement. There is a hidden and concealed point[B] there that is not known, and a single pillar is fixed from below upward within that point. From there flow waters that separate into the four directions of the world. This point receives from the Supernal Mother[4] (Imma Ila'ah), and Jerusalem is in the middle of the inhabited world, for in these

[A] Or: "beyond the ocean at the equatorial line" — This is a more literal translation of 'kav hashaveh' which specifically refers to the equatorial line in medieval geographical terminology.

[B] Or: "buried and treasured point" — The terms 'tmunah' and 'gnuzah' have connotations of being deliberately hidden away as something precious, which 'buried and treasured' might better capture.

[1] This refers to another work by the author, whose title means 'Illuminators of Dawn,' possibly referring to a prayer society in Modena that gathered for morning prayers, as mentioned elsewhere in the text.

[2] The Hebrew term used here is 'chochmat ha-chabalah,' literally 'the wisdom of the bond/cable,' an uncommon designation for Kabbalah that emphasizes its function in connecting or binding humans to the divine realm.

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'ונדעה נרדפה' combines two verbs from Hosea 6:3 ('let us know, let us pursue') creating a sense of active spiritual inquiry rather than mere academic study.

[4] The term 'Imma Ila'ah' (Supernal Mother) refers to the sefirah of Binah (Understanding) in Kabbalah, which is conceptualized as the divine feminine principle that gives birth to the lower sefirot.

[i] The term 'Kabbalah' is here referred to as 'chochmat ha-chabalah' (wisdom of the bond/cable) rather than the more common 'chochmat ha-nistar' (hidden wisdom) or 'chochmat ha-emet' (wisdom of truth), emphasizing its function in binding or connecting the human and divine realms.

[ii] Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author refers to his own work 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), where he apparently discusses the importance of studying Kabbalah and the consequences of neglecting it. This self-reference indicates the author's broader literary output beyond Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Gaon of Fano — The reference to Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano (1548-1620) as 'my teacher' establishes the author's intellectual lineage within Italian Kabbalah. This important kabbalist was a prolific writer who synthesized Cordoverian and Lurianic Kabbalah, and his mention helps date and contextualize the work.

נקודין מתפרשת למלכות שמים שהוא צד הקדושה. אחת נקודה המוקבלת להשפעת מלכות שהיא במקום ב״ה וירושלים ואחת להשפעת אימא עילאה שהוא מקום ג״ע ויש נקודה אחרא באמצע החרבן ששם היו משלחין ישראל השעיר למדבר. ואמרו בפ׳ תצוה דף ק״פ שאפי׳ בזמן שישראל בגלות ומתפללים כל יוה״כ שהשכינה עולה לפני המלך לתבוע על בניה. על כן שענו במעירי שחר שלנו תפלה לזווגא דמטרוניתא בבקר יוה״כ שחובה עלינו להקדים להתפלל בשלומה של מלכות שמים ביום אשר היא מכינה עצמה לתבוע מן המלך עליה ועל בניה. הנה שג״ע הוא באמצע העולם ואמרו שנטוע בכח שם שלם כגוונא דג״ע עליון שבו נכלל הדין ברחמים [i]

two points the Kingdom of Heaven,[1] which is the side of holiness, is divided. One point corresponds to the influence of Malkhut, which is in the place of the Holy Temple and Jerusalem, and one corresponds to the influence of the Supernal Mother, which is the location of the Garden of Eden. And there is another point in the middle of the desolation, where Israel used to send the scapegoat into the wilderness. 15R 20R

And they said in Parshat Tetzaveh, page 180, that even in times when Israel is in exile and praying throughout Yom Kippur, the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) ascends before the King[2] to plead on behalf of her children. Therefore, we established in our "Illuminators of Dawn" prayer group a prayer[A] for the unification of the Divine Feminine[3] (Matronita) on the morning of Yom Kippur, for it is our obligation to precede our prayers with a prayer for the welfare of the Kingdom of Heaven on the day when she prepares herself to make claims before the King concerning herself and her children. Thus, the Garden of Eden is in the middle of the world, and they said that it is planted through the power of the complete divine Name, similar to the supernal Garden of Eden, in which judgment is included within mercy.[4] 25R 30R 35R

ורחמים בדין וכל הדיוקנאות

...and mercy with judgment, and all the supernal

[A] Or: "Therefore, we instituted in our "Illuminators of Dawn" prayer group a prayer" — The verb 'sha'anu' might be better rendered as 'instituted' in this context, as it refers to the formal establishment of a prayer ritual.

[1] The text describes a kabbalistic geography where divine influence flows through specific metaphysical points. Jerusalem receives from Malkhut (Kingdom), while the Garden of Eden receives from Binah (Supernal Mother).

[2] In kabbalistic symbolism, the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) is often portrayed as a feminine aspect of divinity that advocates for Israel before God, particularly on Yom Kippur.

[3] The phrase 'zivuga d'matronita' refers to the mystical unification of masculine and feminine divine aspects, a central concept in Kabbalah that practitioners sought to facilitate through prayer.

[4] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that in higher spiritual realms, seemingly contradictory divine attributes exist in perfect harmony, with the attribute of judgment (Din) being 'sweetened' by its inclusion within mercy (Rachamim).

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parshat Tetzaveh — The author cites this Zohar passage to establish a connection between earthly prayer practices and cosmic processes, particularly explaining why the prayer group 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn) established special prayers on Yom Kippur morning for the unification of the Divine Feminine. | Cf. Zohar teachings on the structure of the Garden of Eden — The author is drawing on Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's teachings in the Zohar about the Garden of Eden's metaphysical structure. This passage combines geographical, mystical, and kabbalistic concepts to describe the Garden not merely as a physical location but as a metaphysical nexus point connecting different cosmic realms. | Cf. Biblical scapegoat ritual — The author connects the mystical geography of the Garden of Eden with other sacred locations, including the place where the scapegoat was sent on Yom Kippur. This creates a kabbalistic mapping where each spiritual location has a specific cosmic function in relation to divine attributes.

עליונות כלם מתרקמים
ומצטיירים בג״ע תחתון
והכרובים ששם אינם לא
מכסף ולא מזהב אלא הם כלם
אורות של מעלה מצוייריים
בציור מעשה ידי אמן דשם שלם
של הקב״ה וכל הדיוקנאות
וצורות של עה״ז כלם מצוייריים
ומחוקקים שם בדמות שהם
בע״הז והוא מקום לרוחות
קדושים בין אותם שבאו לעה״ז
בין אותם שלא באו עדיין ואותם
המוכנים לבא וכל הרוחין
מתלבשים בלבושים וגופים
ופרצופין בגוון עוה״ז ורואין
שם בזיו כבוד דקב״ה עד שבאים
לעה״ז כי אז מתפשטים מאותו
גוף ולבוש ששם מעין רוחניות
אותו אויר הקדוש ומתלבשים
בגוף מעין אויר וגשמיות עוה״ז
וכיון שמגיע זמנו למות מתפשט
מלבוש הגוף הזה (דיש לסטרא
בישא חלק בו) ע״י מלאך המות
ואז הולך ומתלבש באותו גוף
האחר שבג״ע שהפשיט אותו בעת
ביאתו לעה״ז לשמרו שם עד
בואו ואין שמחה לרוח רק בעודו
לבוש בגוף ההוא ושמח על
שנתפשט מגוף העה״ז ואתלבש
בלבוש אחר שלם כדוגמא
שהיה בעה״ז וע״י אותו לבוש
זך מספיריות הגן בו מסתכל
בסודות עליונים מה שלא היה
יכול לידע ולהבין בעה״ז וכמה
עדונין וכסופין יש לרוח בלבוש
ההוא ובלבוש הזה יזכה "לראות
בגנים "וללקוט "שושנים ר״ת
לבו״ש. מזה יתאמת ג״כ מה
שכתבנו בפרקים הקודמים
משמירת התורה ומצות לצדיקים
אחר המות בג״ע. והקב״ה אינו
מפשיט לרוח הזה לבושים אלו
שבג״ע עד שמתקין לו לבושים

forms are embroidered and depicted in the lower Garden of Eden. The cherubim there are neither of silver nor of gold, but are entirely supernal lights, portrayed as artful handiwork of the complete Name of the Holy One, blessed be He. All the images and forms of this world are depicted and engraved there in the likeness of how they appear in this world. It is a place for holy spirits—both those who have already come to this world, those who have not yet come, and those who are prepared to come. All these spirits clothe themselves in garments, bodies, and countenances resembling those of this world, and there they behold the radiance of the Holy One, blessed be He's glory.[1] When they come to this world, they divest themselves of that body and garment, which is of the spiritual essence of that holy atmosphere, and clothe themselves in a body resembling the air and physicality of this world.[2] When the time comes for one to die, he is divested of this afflicted garment (in which the evil side has a portion) by the Angel of Death. Then he proceeds to clothe himself in that other body that is in the Garden of Eden, which he removed upon his entry into this world and which was preserved there until his return. The spirit finds joy only when clothed in that body, and rejoices that it has been stripped of the body of this world and clothed in another complete garment resembling what it had in this world. Through that pure garment from the translucence of the Garden, one gazes upon supernal mysteries that one was unable to know and understand in this world. What delights and longings the spirit experiences in that garment! And in this garment, one merits "to see in the gardens and gather lilies"—the initial letters of which spell out "garment" (levush). This also confirms what we wrote in previous chapters about the preservation of Torah and commandments for the righteous after death in the Garden of Eden. The Holy One, blessed be He, does not remove these garments of the Garden of Eden from this spirit until He prepares other garments for it that are more precious and better than these, according to the translucence of the supernal worlds in which it will delight in the future,

[1] This 'radiance' (ziv kavod) refers to an attenuated form of divine revelation that souls can experience without being overwhelmed by direct divine light—a common concept in Jewish mystical literature.

[2] The text presents a sophisticated understanding of the soul's journey, where it transitions between different types of 'bodies' or vessels appropriate to each realm it inhabits—spiritual bodies in the Garden of Eden and physical bodies in this world.

אחרים יקרים וטובים מאלו לפי ספיריות עולמות עליונים שעתיד להשתעשע בהם כפי מעשיו חוץ מרשעים שמתו אפי׳ בלא הרהורי תשובה שערומים ישובו שם ר״ל. והמהרהר תשובה מצפצף ועולה פירוש מצפצף כי רצון טוב שהרהר עולה ויורד לפני הקב״ה ושובר כל שערי גיהנם [i]

in accordance with its deeds—except for the wicked who died without even thoughts of repentance, who return there naked, Heaven forbid. But one who contemplates repentance chirps and ascends[1]—meaning that the good intention that one contemplated rises and descends before the Holy One, blessed be He, and breaks through all the gates of Gehenna.[2] 85R

ומגיע למדור הנקרא שאול ששם ירד רשע זה ואז מצפצפת אותה נשמה לעלות משאול ואין שום רצון טוב שמתאבד מלפני הקב״ה ואשרי המהרהר הרהורי מצוה ולבו תאב להביאן לידי גמר [ii] כאשר בארנו למעלה ועליהם נאמר מוריד שאול ויעל. פוק חזי דברי החכם אלשיך בפ׳ בראשית על דרוש אילנות ונטיעות ג״ע כי יערב לך. [iii] ואמרו במקום אחר שג״ע תחתון הוא כלול משני דוגמות דוגמת העה״ז ודוגמת עולם של מעלה. ואמרו בויקרא רבה פרשה י״א אור שברא הקב״ה ביום ראשון היכן גנזו בג״ע שנאמר אור זרוע לצדיק וגו׳ ואם מלאכי השרת אינם ניזונים

...and reaches the dwelling place called Sheol where this wicked one descended, and then that soul chirps to ascend from Sheol. No good intention is ever lost before the Holy One, blessed be He, and fortunate is one who contemplates thoughts of commandments and whose heart yearns to bring them to completion, as we explained above. Of them it is said, "He brings down to Sheol and raises up" (1 Samuel 2:6). Go and see the words of the sage Alshich in his commentary on Genesis regarding the discourse on trees and plantings of the Garden of Eden, for it will be pleasant to you. 90R 95R 100R

They said in another place that the lower Garden of Eden encompasses two models: a model of this world and a model of the world above. And they said in Leviticus Rabbah, chapter 11, that the light which the Holy One, blessed be He, created on the first day—where did He store it? In the Garden of Eden, as it is said, "Light is sown for the righteous" 105R

[1] The Hebrew metaphor of 'chirping' (metzaftzef) for a soul's expression compares it to a bird's song—suggesting a preliminary, incomplete form of spiritual expression that nonetheless has redemptive power.

[2] This powerful image of repentance breaking through the gates of Gehenna suggests that sincere contrition has the spiritual power to overcome postmortem punishment, reflecting the rabbinic concept that 'nothing stands before repentance.'

[i] Cf. Zohar — The text follows the Zoharic tradition of describing the Garden of Eden as a spiritual realm where souls reside both before birth and after death, and where they are clothed in spiritual garments corresponding to their deeds and spiritual level. | Cf. Song of Songs — This biblical verse is reinterpreted mystically as referring to the spiritual activities of souls in the Garden of Eden, with the author noting that the initial letters of these words in Hebrew spell out 'garment' (לבו״ש), connecting the verse to the theme of spiritual garments. | Cf. Earlier chapters of Ma'avar Yabok — The author is creating internal coherence within the book by referencing earlier discussions about how the righteous continue to observe Torah and commandments in the Garden of Eden after death. | Cf. Kabbalistic tradition on repentance — This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that intention (kavanah) has spiritual power and that even incomplete repentance can effect cosmic changes, particularly in mitigating postmortem punishment.

[ii] This concept that good intentions and desire to fulfill commandments have spiritual value even if not completed is a significant theological principle in Jewish thought.

[iii] The author refers to the biblical commentary of Rabbi Moshe Alshich (1508-1593), a prominent Safed kabbalist whose writings on Genesis discuss the Garden of Eden in detail.

אלא מזיו השכינה כדאמרו בש״ר
פרשה ל״ב כ״ש הצדיקים בג״ע
כי יזכו להארת אור עץ החיים
כאשר יבא לפנינו אם יגזור ה׳ כי
אפי׳ בעה״ז הצדיקים אלהיהם
מתקיים עליהם כדאי׳ בבראשית
רבה פ׳ ס״ט. ובזהר פ׳ וארא דף
כ״ג אמר דגופא דאדם הראשון
ג״כ אתחבר מתרין עלמין מעלמא
דא תתאה ומעלמא דלעילא ולכן
הדיוקנאות של בני אדם שוכנים
בג״ע תחתון ואמר שם בדף כ״ד
ע״ב דכי היכי דמעפר מקדשא
לתתא אתחברו ביה תלת סטרין
יסודי עלמא דאינון אש רוח
מים הכי נמי מעפרא דמקדשא
דלעילא אתיהב ביה נשמתא
ואתחברו תלת סטרי יסודי
עלמא ואשתלים אדם וכבר נודע
מה שנמצא כתוב בג״ע תחתון
בדברי רבותינו כי רבי יהושע
שנכנס חי בג״ע[i] שלח לרב״ג
תבנית ומדות הג״ע וחומותיו
הפנימיות והחצונות והיכליו
ותאיו ואולמיו הכל השביל אותו
בכתב אמת רשום והם ודבריהם
אמת ותאלמנה שפתי שקר.
ואמרו כי בג״ע אין שם עצבון כי
לויתן ראשו בג״ע וכתיב לפניו
תדוך דאבה[ii] ואמרו ג״כ כי
כשהצדיקים יושבים בבגדיהם
ולבושיהם הנאים ובעדונים
רבים הרשעים עומדים מבחוץ
ורואים ממרחק ויש רשעים
גמורים שאינן מניחין אותם
לראות אלא ע״י שמועה שמגידים
להם ויש להם רשות לפעמים
להקיף הצדיקים ולראות דרך
חורין וסדקין סביב רשעים
יתהלכון. הנה כי בג״ע תחתון בו
שעשועים גדולים והוא בהרבה
בחינות מעין העה״ז. ועיין מזה
בפ׳ כ״ז וכ״ט מחלק העבודה

(Psalms 97:11), etc. And if the ministering angels are sustained only from the radiance of the Divine Presence, as they said in Shemot Rabbah, chapter 32, how much more so will the righteous in the Garden of Eden merit the illumination of the light of the Tree of Life, as will come before us if God decrees, for even in this world, "the righteous—their God stands by them," as stated in Genesis Rabbah, chapter 69. 110R 115R

In the Zohar, parashat Va'era, page 23, it states that the body of Adam was also formed from two worlds—from this lower world and from the world above—and therefore the forms of human beings dwell in the lower Garden of Eden. And it says there on page 24b that just as from the earth of the lower sanctuary, three aspects of the world's elements—fire, wind, and water—were joined within him, so too from the earth of the upper sanctuary was his soul given to him, and the three aspects of the world's elements were joined, and Adam was completed. 120R 125R

It is already known what is found written about the lower Garden of Eden in the words of our Rabbis, that Rabbi Joshua, who entered the Garden of Eden alive, sent to Rabban Gamliel a blueprint and measurements of the Garden of Eden, its inner and outer walls, its chambers, compartments, and halls—all of which he understood in true writing, inscribed. They and their words are truth, and the lips of falsehood will be silenced. 130R 135R

They said that in the Garden of Eden there is no sorrow, for Leviathan's head is in the Garden of Eden, and it is written, "Before him sorrow flees" (Job 41:22). They also said that when the righteous sit in their garments and beautiful clothes and in great delights, the wicked stand outside and see from afar. There are completely wicked ones who are not permitted to see except through hearsay that is told to them. Sometimes they have permission to encircle the righteous and to see through holes and cracks—"all around, the wicked walk" (Psalms 12:9). 140R 145R

Indeed, in the lower Garden of Eden there are great delights, and in many aspects, it is like this world. See more about this in chapters 27 and 29 of 150R

[i] This refers to a Talmudic tradition about Rabbi Joshua ben Levi who reportedly entered Paradise alive. The story appears in tractate Ketubot 77b, where he tricks the Angel of Death and enters Paradise without dying.

[ii] This connects the presence of Leviathan in the Garden of Eden with the cessation of sorrow, based on Job 41:22. In Jewish mysticism, Leviathan represents a cosmic force whose presence brings joy.

בעבודת הקדש. ואילנות ג״ע
עושים פרי לעד לעולם בארץ
155 לא יזקין שרשם ובעפר לא
ימות גזעם ואין צריכים לעובד
דזומר כי הם נטיעות ה׳ דכתיב
ויטע ה׳ אלהים וקיומו לעולם
כמ״ש לא יבול עלהו ולא יתום
160 פריו כי מן המקדש יוצאים
ואדמת גן עדן היה צריך עבוד
ושמור. והדברים שבגן הם יסוד
ורוחניות לכל הדברים אשר
בארץ כמו שדרשו הביאני המלך
165 חדריו זה חדרי ג״ע וכן אמרו
במעשה הרקיע כן מעשה ג״ע
והנהרות נגד ארבע מחנות שכינה
שעליהם הכסא נכון[i] ומשם נמשך
כח למלאכים והגן מעלה דשאים
170 ממים חיים שהיא שפע בינה
היוצאים ממעין הנובע מחכמה
עד האין סוף[ii] והם מים שאין
להם סוף ומג״ע נשפעים ונאצלים
כל בעלי חיים וצמחים ויציצו
175 ויפרחו. ובזה לא יהיה נמנע
לצדיקים לראות את עולמם
בחייהם:[iii]

the "Service" section in Avodat HaKodesh.

The trees of the Garden of Eden produce fruit forever and ever; in the earth, their roots do not age, and in the dust, their trunks do not die. They 155R
do not need a worker to prune them, for they are the plantings of the Lord, as it is written, "And the Lord God planted" (Genesis 2:8), and their existence is eternal, as it is said, "Its leaf shall not wither, neither shall its fruit fail" (Ezekiel 47:12), for they 160R
come forth from the sanctuary. And the soil of the Garden of Eden required working and guarding.

The things in the garden are the foundation and spirituality for all things on earth, as they interpreted, "The king has brought me into his chambers" 165R
(Song of Songs 1:4)—these are the chambers of the Garden of Eden. They also said that as is the work of the firmament, so is the work of the Garden of Eden. The rivers correspond to the four camps of the Divine Presence upon which the throne is estab- 170R
lished, and from there, power flows to the angels. The garden raises grasses from living waters, which are the influx of Binah (Understanding) flowing from the spring that flows from Chokhmah (Wisdom) to the Ein Sof (Infinite One), and they are waters that 175R
have no end. From the Garden of Eden flow and emanate all living beings and plants, and they blossom and flourish. And thus, it will not be impossible for the righteous to see their world in their lifetime.

[i] This describes the four rivers of Eden (Genesis 2:10-14) as corresponding to the four angelic camps that uphold the Divine Throne in Ezekiel's vision. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that earthly geography mirrors celestial structures.

[ii] This passage uses technical kabbalistic terminology to describe divine emanation, where vegetation in the Garden grows from 'living waters' that represent divine influx flowing from the sefirah of Binah (Understanding), which itself receives from Chokhmah (Wisdom) and ultimately from Ein Sof (the Infinite).

[iii] Cf. 1 Samuel 2:6 — Used to emphasize that even those who have spiritually descended to Sheol (the wicked) can be elevated through genuine spiritual intention | Cf. Genesis 2:8 — Used to emphasize the divine origin of the Garden, explaining why its trees are eternal unlike earthly trees | Cf. Ezekiel 47:12 — Applied to Garden of Eden trees to show their eternal and perfect nature | Cf. Psalms 97:11 — Used to explain where the primordial light of creation was stored—in the Garden of Eden for the righteous | Cf. Job 41:22 — Applied to show that the Garden of Eden is free from sorrow, since Leviathan's presence there drives away all sadness | Cf. Psalms 12:9 — Used to describe how wicked souls may observe the righteous in the Garden of Eden but only from outside through cracks | Cf. Song of Songs 1:4 — Mystically interpreted to refer to the chambers of the Garden of Eden | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Va'era — Used to explain why human forms/souls dwell in the lower Garden of Eden—because humans are composed of both physical and spiritual elements | Cf. Leviticus Rabbah, chapter 11 — Used to establish that the primordial light is stored in the Garden of Eden for the righteous | Cf. Genesis Rabbah, chapter 69 — Used to argue that if God sustains the righteous in this world, they will certainly experience the divine light in the Garden of Eden | Cf. Avodat HaKodesh — Referenced as a source for further reading on the mystical nature of the Garden of Eden

פרק ל״ה

Chapter 35

מדברי ספר הזהר מוכח כי בג״ע של מטה יש סודות עליונות ברקיע העומד עליו כי כשעשה הקב״ה רקיע[i] הביא אש ומים מתוך כסא כבודו ושתף אותם יחד ועשה מהם שמים למטה ונתפשטו עד שהגיעו למקום ג״ע ושם עמדו מה עשה הקב״ה נטל משמים קדושים עליונים אש ומים אחרים שמתגלים ואינם מתגלים והם אש ומים שנטלו מהשמים עליונים ועשה מהם רקיע שבו ד׳ גוונים ובו ד׳ פתחים ושם מאורות הרבה כמו שפירשו רבנן במקומו ומתראים שם מרכבות מיכאל ורפאל העומדים על הנשמה ואומרים יבא שלום יבא שלום ומרכבות גבריאל ונוריאל יורדים מב׳ פתחים אחרים ועומדים על הנשמה ומשם נכנסים תוך היכל גנוז בג״ע הנקרא אהלות ושם י״ב מיני בשמים ושם כל לבושי הנשמות כל אחד כפי מדרגתו ובלבושים ההם נרשמים כל המעשים טובים שעשה בעוה״ז ונרשם בו זה לבוש פלוני[ii] ומלבישים הנשמה ההיא בדיוקן עוה״ז כנזכר וזהו אחר ל׳ יום דכל ל׳ יום אין נשמה שלא תקבל ענשה קודם שתכנס לג״ע ואחר הלבון נותנים

From the words of the Zohar it is proven that in the lower Garden of Eden there are sublime mysteries in the firmament standing above it.[A] For when the Holy One, blessed be He, created the firmament, He brought fire and water from within His throne 5R
of glory and combined them together, making from them the lower heavens. These extended until they reached the place of the Garden of Eden, where they stood. What did the Holy One, blessed be He, do? He took from the higher holy heavens other fire and 10R
water that are both revealed and not revealed[B]—fire and water taken from the supernal heavens—and made from them a firmament containing four colors and four openings, with many luminaries, as our Rabbis explained in its proper place. There appear 15R
the chariots of Michael and Raphael, who stand over the soul and say, "May peace come, may peace come," while the chariots of Gabriel and Noriel descend from two other openings, stand over the soul, and from there enter a hidden chamber in the 20R
Garden of Eden called "Ahalot" (Aloes).[C] There are twelve kinds of fragrances there, and there are all the garments of souls, each according to its level. In these garments are inscribed all the good deeds that one performed in this world, and it is inscribed: 25R
"This is the garment of so-and-so." They clothe that soul in the likeness of this world, as mentioned. This happens after thirty days, for during the first thirty days, no soul escapes receiving its punishment before entering the Garden of Eden, and after the 30R
purification, it is given its place.

[A] Or: "that in the terrestrial Garden of Eden there are supernal secrets in the firmament positioned above it" — The term 'של מטה' can be translated as either 'lower' or more specifically 'terrestrial/earthly', contrasting with the celestial Garden. Similarly, 'סודות עליונות' could be rendered as 'supernal secrets' rather than 'sublime mysteries' to better preserve the technical kabbalistic terminology.

[B] Or: "that manifest yet remain concealed" — The paradoxical nature of this divine fire and water might be better conveyed with the contrasting terms 'manifest' and 'concealed', which more directly capture the mystical concept of simultaneous revelation and hiddenness.

[C] Or: "an archived palace in the Garden of Eden called "Ahalot"" — The term 'היכל' specifically refers to a palace or temple hall in kabbalistic literature rather than simply a chamber, and 'גנוז' carries connotations of being archived or treasured away, not just hidden. The transliteration 'Ahalot' could stand without the explanatory 'Aloes' as it is a technical term.

[i] The author begins with a cosmological description drawn from the Zohar, explaining the mystical structure of the heavens in relation to the Garden of Eden.

[ii] This passage describes how the souls' garments in the afterlife are inscribed with records of their good deeds performed in this world, suggesting a form of spiritual accounting.

לה מקומה.[i] ומרקיע ג״ע נוטף
טל מהאותיות החקוקות בו
ובו מתרחצים הנשמות להטהר
ורקיע ההוא הוא סוד התורה
ומהאש ומים של התורה נעשה.
ועל כן ממשיכים מאותו טל על
עוסקי בתורה לשמה כי דבריהם
נרשמים בג״ע ועולים עד אותו
רקיע ה״ד יערוף כמטר לקחי
תזל כטל אמרתי.[ii] באמצע
רקיע זה בו פתח אחד שדרך
בו פורחים הנשמות לג״ע עליון
דרך עמוד ששם וברקיע ההוא
יש ג׳ מיני גווני אורות המאירים
לגווני עמוד ההוא ואז הרקיע
הזה מתנוצץ ומתלהט בכמה מיני
אורות המתלהטים ובכל שעה
הצדיקים מאירים מאותו אור
עליון אבל בכל שבת וראש חדש
מתגלית השכינה ביותר משאר
פעמים ברקיע הזה וכל הצדיקים
משתחוים לגבה ולבושים אלו הם
ממעשי המצות. אבל בשעולה
הנשמה בפתח של רקיע למעלה
מזדמנים לה לבושים אחרים
יקרים עליונים שהם מרצון
וכוונת התורה והתפלה בשעולה
מתעטר מכתר התפלה הראוי
להתעטר למעלה ונשאר אלקו
לאיש ההוא ונעשה ממנו לבושי
אור להתלבש הנשמה לעלות
למעלה תוך המלאכים רוחין
קדישין הכי פירש אליהו לר׳
שמעון בן יוחאי כי לבושים
של ג״ע תחתון הם ממעשים

From the firmament of the Garden of Eden drops dew from the letters engraved upon it, and in this dew the souls bathe to purify themselves. This firmament is the mystery of the Torah, and it is made from the fire and water of the Torah.[1] Therefore, they draw from that dew upon those who engage in Torah for its own sake, for their words are inscribed in the Garden of Eden and ascend to that firmament. This is as it is written: "My teaching shall drop like rain, my words shall flow like dew."

In the middle of this firmament is an opening through which souls fly to the upper Garden of Eden by way of a column that is there. In that firmament there are three types of colored lights that illuminate the colors of that column, and then this firmament sparkles and blazes with many kinds of flaming lights. At all times, the righteous shine from that supernal light, but during every Sabbath and New Moon, the Divine Presence is revealed more prominently than at other times in this firmament, and all the righteous bow to Her.[2] These garments are from the performance of commandments. But when the soul ascends through the opening of the firmament above, other precious supernal garments are prepared for it, which come from the will and intention behind one's Torah study and prayer. When it ascends, it is crowned with the crown of prayer worthy to be crowned above, and a portion remains for that person, becoming garments of light in which the soul dresses to ascend above among the angels, the holy spirits. Thus did Elijah explain to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai that the garments of the lower Garden of Eden come from deeds, while the higher garments come from will and intention of the heart.[3]

In the lower Garden of Eden, a river flows forth,

[1] The text creates a parallel between the physical formation of the heavens from divine fire and water, and the formation of the firmament of Eden from the conceptual 'fire and water' of Torah, suggesting that Torah study mirrors cosmic creation.

[2] The feminine pronoun refers to the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), which in Kabbalah represents the feminine aspect of divinity. The text describes how it manifests more intensely on Sabbaths and New Moons in the Garden of Eden.

[3] This passage presents a kabbalistic hierarchy of spiritual garments, where deeds create lower garments but intentions and devotion create higher ones, emphasizing the importance of inner devotion over mere external actions.

[i] The term 'לבון' (libun/purification) implies a process of spiritual refinement, similar to the purification of metals, that souls undergo before entering the Garden of Eden.

[ii] The author cites Deuteronomy 32:2, interpreting this verse about Torah as rain/dew as a reference to the metaphysical dew that nourishes souls in the Garden of Eden and those who study Torah in this world.

ולבושים עליונים מרצון וכוונת
הלב. ובגן עדן תחתון נהר יוצא
ושרשו הוא מעדן ולהיות כי
עדן עליון סתום וגנוז גם עדן
תחתון שממנו יוצא אותו נהר
סתום ואפי׳ מאותם הנשמות
שבגן עדן וכמו שלמטה נהר זה
מתפרש מעדן להשקות הגן הכי
נמי מפתח אמצעי שבגן עליון
יוצא אור המתפרש לארבע
רוחות מארבע פתחים שאמרנו
ואור זה המתפשט לארבע אורות
בארבע אותיות יוצא מעדן
מקום המאיר נקודה תחתונה
נגד מעלה ונקודה זו מתנהרת
ונעשית עדן לאיר באינה נראית
הנקודה רק האור המתפרש ממנה
משתחוים כנגדו הצדיקים שבגן
בנזכר. ונקודה זו תחתונה היא
גן לגבי עדן שלמעלה[i] מקום
שלא ניתן לידע ולהסתכל על
זה כתוב עין לא ראתה אלהים
זולתך[ii] זה עדן עליון סוד
עוה״ב האוחז למעלה מעלה
עד אין סוף הוא יודע לנקודה
תחתונה שהיא נקודת בת ציון
בתר צדיק שהוא יסוד נהר דרוי
לה ונהר היוצא מעדן למטה הוא
סוד והשביע בצחצחות נפשך
כי הנשמה היוצאת מעולם זה
החשוך היא תאבה לראות באיש
התאב למים. וצחצחות הוא לשון
צחה צמא.[iii] צמא מאותן צחות

and its root is from Eden. And since the upper Eden is hidden and concealed, the lower Eden from which this river emerges is also concealed, even from the souls in the Garden of Eden. And just as below, this river separates from Eden to water the garden, similarly, from the middle opening in the upper garden emerges a light that separates into four directions through the four openings we mentioned. This light, which expands into four lights corresponding to the four letters, emerges from Eden, the place that illuminates the lower point toward the height. This point becomes illuminated and becomes Eden to give light, though the point itself is not visible—only the light that emanates from it. The righteous in the garden bow before it, as mentioned. This lower point is a garden in relation to the Eden above, a place that cannot be known or perceived. Concerning this it is written: "No eye has seen God besides You"—this refers to the upper Eden, the mystery of the World to Come, which extends upward beyond limit to the Infinite One. He knows the lower point, which is the point of the Daughter of Zion, after the Righteous One, which is Yesod,[1] the river that quenches her thirst.

The river flowing from Eden below is the mystery of "He will satisfy your soul in drought,"[A] for the soul that emerges from this dark world yearns to see, like a person who thirsts for water. The term "tzachtzachot" (drought) is related to the language of "tzacheh" (thirsty)—thirsty for the clarity of the luminaries of the garden, the firmament, and the chambers of the garden. All the souls in their precious garments sit by that river, for without that

[A] Or: "The river flowing from Eden below embodies the secret of "He will satisfy your soul with radiant splendors,"" — The term 'צחצחות' in Isaiah 58:11 is often interpreted in kabbalistic texts not as 'drought' but as 'radiant splendors' or 'clear brilliance,' referring to divine illumination rather than thirst. This interpretation better fits the context of souls being nourished by divine light.

[1] These terms refer to specific sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah: 'Daughter of Zion' refers to Malkhut (the lowest sefirah representing divine presence in the world), while 'the Righteous One' and 'Yesod' refer to the ninth sefirah representing the cosmic channel connecting higher realms to Malkhut.

[i] This presents a sophisticated hierarchical cosmology where Eden itself is distinguished from the Garden (Gan), with Eden being a higher, more concealed realm that feeds the Garden below it.
[ii] The author cites Isaiah 64:3 to describe the completely transcendent nature of the upper Eden, identifying it with the World to Come that extends infinitely upward.
[iii] The author provides an etymological explanation of the term 'צחצחות' from Isaiah 58:11, relating it to thirst and clarity, which helps explain why souls desire the spiritual illumination of the Garden.

דמאורות הגן ורקיע והיכלות
הגן וכל הנשמות בלבושיהם
היקרים יושבים על ההוא נהר
שאלמלא לבוש ההוא לא היו
יכולים לסבול ונהר ההוא
הוא תקון הנשמות להתיישב
ולזון וליהנות מאותן צחות.
וכבר נשאו נהרות קולם ודכים
להעיד על אמיתת גן עדן ועציו
ונהרותיו בכל קצות הארץ ושאין
ג״כ לספק כי עץ החיים אשר
בתוך הגן לטוב מזגו ושווי טעמו
תהיה מסגולתו אשר כל אוכליו
יאריכו ימים רבים או יחיו לעד
כמו שכתב הרמב״ן[i] ועיין בשער
עשירי בבעל העקדה דף ר״ט
ע״ב בסופו כי הכריח דברים
אלו ממעשים העושים חכמים
הטבעיים בכל יום הגם כי עדות
ה׳ נאמנה מצד עצמה ובזהר פ׳
שמות דף י״א ע״א על פסוק וילך
איש מבית לוי מבאר איך מתגלם
רוח האדם בגן עדן תחתון קודם
בואו לעולם והכריח מכל שכן
שמתגלם שם אחר בואו בשובו
למנוחתו בגן עדן ההוא ואיך זה
ובדף י״ג ע״א מביא מעשה רב
על זה[ii] ומתוכו מתאמת מציאות
גן עדן תחתון כפשוטן של דברים
יעויין שם:[iii]

garment, they could not endure it.[1] That river is the rectification of souls, enabling them to settle, to be nourished, and to enjoy those clarities. 100R

Rivers have already lifted up their voices and pounded to testify to the truth of the Garden of Eden, its trees, and its rivers in all corners of the earth. There is also no reason to doubt that the Tree of Life, which is in the midst of the garden, with its good temperament and balanced taste, has the special property that all who eat from it will live many days or live forever, as Nachmanides wrote. 105R 110R See the tenth gate in the Akedah, page 209b at the end, where he proves these matters from the works of natural scientists[2] every day, although the testimony of the Lord is faithful in and of itself. In the Zohar, Parashat Shemot, page 11a, on the verse "And a man of the house of Levi went," it explains how the spirit of a person is embodied in the lower Garden of Eden before coming into the world, and it proves a fortiori that it is embodied there after its arrival,[3] when it returns to its rest in that Garden of Eden, and how this works. And on page 13a, it brings a great story about this, and from it the existence of the lower Garden of Eden is confirmed in the plain meaning of things, see there. 115R 120R

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that souls require protective 'garments' to withstand divine radiance, just as Moses needed protection to see God's glory in Exodus 33:22.

[2] The author cites both religious authorities (Nachmanides) and philosophical works (the Akedah by Rabbi Isaac Arama) that use natural science to support the literal existence of the Garden of Eden, showing an integration of mystical, theological, and proto-scientific approaches.

[3] The text presents a complete cycle of the soul's journey: it begins in the Garden of Eden before birth, enters the world, and returns to the Garden after death, suggesting a pre-existence of souls before their earthly incarnation.

[i] The author cites Nachmanides (Ramban) regarding the immortality-granting properties of the Tree of Life, suggesting a literal interpretation of the Garden of Eden and its features.

[ii] The author appeals to a story in the Zohar as evidence for the existence of the lower Garden of Eden, showing how kabbalistic literature is used to validate theological claims about the afterlife.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shemot — The text explicitly cites this section of the Zohar regarding how the human spirit is embodied in the lower Garden of Eden before entering the world and returns there after death, using it as textual proof for the physical reality of the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — The text interprets this verse as describing how souls in the Garden of Eden are spiritually nourished by the river flowing from Eden, using the concept of 'tzachtzachot' (typically translated as 'drought' but interpreted here as spiritual clarity or brilliance) as a metaphor for divine illumination. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:2 — This verse is cited to explain how the dew from the firmament of Eden nourishes those who study Torah for its own sake, creating a parallel between

פרק ל״ו

Chapter 36

הנהר של מעלה שאמרנו מוציא נשמות וממנו פורחים לתוך הגן ונהר שהוא בגן עדן תחתון מתקן הנשמות להתיישב ולזון וליהנות מאותן צחות כדוגמא שבעולם הזה ריח המים לבד מישב הנפש להאיר ולפי שמתהנים הנשמות על ההוא נהר דנגיד ונפיק מעדן יכולים להתיישב באינון צחות עליונים ולעלות למעלה. סביב העמוד העולה למעלה לפתח הרקיע סביבו יש ענן ועשן מחוץ ונגה מבפנים וזה לחפות על העולים למעלה לבל יתראו מאותם שיושבים למטה. ובשבתות ובחגים ובמועדים כשהקב״ה רוצה להתלבש בלבוש מלכות שולח ד׳ פנים של נשר ועומדים על היכל הנקראת דרור והיינו מר דרור והם נותנים קול ואין מי ששומע אותן רק אותם הנשמות שהם ראויות לעלות ומתקבצים שם ונוטלים ד׳ פנים אלו ומכניסים אותם תוך העמוד העומד באמצע ואז עולה אותו העמוד וענן ואש ועשן ונגה מלגו וב׳ אלו נקראים מכון הר ציון ומקראיה מכון הר ציון דא תקון עליון כשנקודה תחתונה מתקשטת והם מקראיה של אותה נקודה המתקשטת. ובעלות אותן נשמות עד פתח הרקיע אז סובב ההוא רקיע סביבות הגן שלש פעמים ומקול נעימות זה יוצאים כל אותן נשמות ורואים

The upper river that we mentioned brings forth souls, and from it they fly into the garden. The river in the lower Garden of Eden prepares the souls to dwell, be nourished, and enjoy those supernal radiances.[1] Just as in this world, the mere scent of water refreshes the soul and illuminates it, so too the souls derive pleasure from that river that flows forth from Eden, enabling them to settle in those supernal radiances and ascend higher. Around the pillar that rises upward to the opening of the firmament, there is cloud and smoke outside and brightness within, which covers those ascending so they cannot be seen by those who remain below. On Sabbaths, festivals, and appointed times, when the Holy One, blessed be He, wishes to clothe Himself in royal garments, He sends four faces of an eagle that stand at the palace called Liberty—that is, pure myrrh—and they make a sound that only those souls worthy of ascension can hear. These souls gather there and take these four faces and bring them into the pillar standing in the center. Then that pillar rises with cloud, fire, smoke, and inner brightness. These two are called "the foundation of Mount Zion and her assemblies." "The foundation of Mount Zion" refers to the supernal rectification when the lower point adorns herself,[2] and "her assemblies" refers to the adornments of that point.

When these souls ascend to the opening of the firmament, that firmament encircles the garden three times, and from the sound of this sweetness, all those souls emerge and behold the sweetness of that firmament. They also see the ascending pillar of fire, cloud, smoke, and radiant brightness, and they all prostrate themselves. Then the souls ascend through that opening until they rise within the circle surrounding that point, and then they see what they

[1]The Hebrew term 'tzachot' (צחות) literally means 'clarity' or 'brightness' but in kabbalistic contexts refers to refined spiritual illuminations or radiances that souls experience in the afterlife.
[2]In Kabbalistic symbolism, the 'lower point' refers to the sefirah of Malkhut (Kingdom), which represents the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) that receives influx from the higher divine emanations. Its 'adornment' refers to its spiritual elevation through the prayers and good deeds of Israel.

Torah study in this world and the spiritual sustenance of souls in the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Nachmanides (Ramban) — The text references Nachmanides' view that the Tree of Life has the property of granting longevity or immortality to those who eat from it, using this as authoritative support for the literal existence of the Garden of Eden and its features. | Cf. Akedah (by Rabbi Isaac Arama) — The text cites this philosophical work as providing scientific evidence for the existence of the Garden of Eden and the Tree of Life, suggesting that even natural philosophers can verify these theological truths.

נעימות של אותו רקיע ורואים ג״כ העמוד העולה אש וענן ועשן ונגה דלהיט ומשתחוים כלם ואז הנשמות עולים בההוא פתח עד שעולים תוך העגול הסובב אותה נקודה ואז רואים מה שרואים. ומתוך אור ושמחה ממה שרואים עולים ויורדים קרובים ורחוקים והיא תאבה להם ומתקשטת באור. ואז אלביש קנאה מאור דצדיק עילאה ומסתכל ביופי הנקודה הזאת ותקונה ואוחז אותה ומעלה לה לגביה ומאיר אור באור והם לאחדים וכל חיילי השמים פותחים ואומרים אשרי העוסקים בתורה ששמחת בוראכם בכם שעטרה של בוראכם מתעטר בכם. ואחר ששני אורות אלו מתייחדים יחד ומאירים אח״כ יורדים ומסתכלים להשתעשע באותם נשמות הצדיקים ומתקנים לון להתעטר למעלה על זה נאמר עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך יעשה למחכה לו.[i] ולאדם הראשון הקב״ה התקין לו שבעה חופות בגן עדן להשתעשע בהם ובטעם עליון בשבע רקיעים למעלה ולבקר בהיכלו בשבע רקיעים למטה ושבעה חופות עליונות היו חופפות עליו להתעטר בהם[ii] ושבעה חופות תחתונות היה עוד בהם להשתעשע בתוכם עד שנמשך אחר ראש פתנים

see.[1] From the light and joy of what they behold, they ascend and descend, both near and far, and she desires them and adorns herself with light. Then, clothed in zeal from the light of the supernal Righteous One,[2] He gazes upon the beauty of this point and its rectification, grasps it, and elevates it to Him. Light illuminates light, and they become unified. All the heavenly hosts open their mouths and say, "Happy are those who engage in Torah, for your Creator rejoices in you, for the crown of your Creator is adorned through you."

After these two lights unite and illuminate together, they descend and gaze with delight upon those souls of the righteous, and prepare them to be crowned above. Concerning this it is said, "No eye has seen, O God, besides You, what He has prepared for those who wait for Him." For Adam, the Holy One, blessed be He, prepared seven canopies in the Garden of Eden for him to delight in, with sublime taste in the seven heavens above, and to visit His palace in the seven firmaments below. Seven supernal canopies hovered over him for him to be crowned with, and there were seven lower canopies for him to delight within, until he was drawn after the serpent's head[3] which the body followed. From this exposition, we see that the delight of the righteous in the Garden of Eden causes the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence, as we explained above.

There are two firmaments: the lower firmament stands upon four living creatures, and from there the female form extends, receiving from behind the male, as it says, "You shall see My back." The upper firmament stands upon supernal living creatures,

[1] This deliberately vague phrasing reflects the ineffable nature of the divine vision experienced by elevated souls. The text implies that certain spiritual experiences are beyond description and can only be referenced indirectly.

[2] The 'supernal Righteous One' (צדיק עילאה) refers to the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation), which in Kabbalah serves as the channel that transmits divine flow from the upper sefirot to Malkhut. It is often associated with the biblical figure of Joseph, who is called 'righteous' (tzaddik).

[3] This refers to Adam's sin in the Garden of Eden. In kabbalistic interpretation, the serpent represents the evil inclination or cosmic forces of impurity that tempted Adam away from his original perfect state where he enjoyed direct divine illumination.

[i] This quotes Isaiah 64:3 (64:4 in some translations): "No eye has seen, O God, besides You, what He has prepared for those who wait for Him." This verse is used to describe the ineffable reward of the righteous in the Garden of Eden.

[ii] The metaphor of "crowning" or "being crowned" (להתעטר) appears frequently in kabbalistic literature to describe the process of spiritual elevation and the adorning of souls and divine attributes with higher light.

שהגוף נמשך אחריו הנה מהנדרש
ראינו כי עדון הצדיקים בג״ע
גורמים יחוד קודשא בריך הוא
ושכינתיה כאשר אמרנו למעלה.
ויש שני רקיעים רקיע של מטה
עומד על ארבע חיון ומשם
מתפשט דיוקן נקבה המקבלת
מאחורי הזכר וזהו וראית את
אחורי[i] ורקיע שלמעלה עומד על
חיות עליונות ושם מתפשט דיוקן
הזכר המשפיע שהוא סוד עליון.
ושני רקיעים אלו א׳ נקרא קצה
השמים ואחד נקרא קצה השמים
ונקודת בת ציון[ii] שהוא נקודה
אמצעית של מלכות למעלה
מתייחדת בצדיק עליון ולמטה
בפירות היוצאים מאותו צדיק
שהם הנשמות היוצאות מיסוד
ואינה מוצאה השעשוע מעלה
ומטה אלא בצדיק והגן הוא
מהאי נקודה הנקרא עדן וראשי
החיות הם ארבע פנים אריה
שור נשר אדם כלל כלם. והם
ארבע ראשי נהרות המגיעים
לכסא הקדוש. ומזיעת החיות
הנושאות הכסא נעשה נהר
דינור[iii] והנשמות בעלייתן
מתרחצות שם ועולות לקרבן
ואינם נשרפות אלא מתרחצות
וק״ו מסלמנדרא[iv] שלהיותה

and there the form of the male who bestows extends, which is a supernal mystery. These two firmaments are called "the end of heaven"—one is called "the end of heaven" and [the other also] "the end of heaven." The point of the daughter of Zion, which is the central point of Malkhut,[1] unites above with the supernal Righteous One and below with the fruits that come from that Righteous One, which are the souls that emerge from Yesod.[2] She finds delight above and below only in the Righteous One, and the garden is from that point called Eden. The heads of the living creatures are four faces—lion, ox, eagle, and man—encompassing all of them.[3] They are the four riverheads that reach the holy throne. 70R 75R 80R

From the perspiration of the living creatures that bear the throne, the River of Fire is formed. When souls ascend, they bathe there and rise as an offering. They are not burned but bathed, which is a fortiori from the salamander, which being of fire, its garment is whitened only in light. Similarly, the soul is from fire, taken from within the holy throne, of which it is written, "His throne was fiery flames." When it wishes to be cleansed of its impurity, it passes through fire and is bathed, and the fire consumes all impurity within it. It experiences pain, for woe to the soul that endures foreign fire, even though it is purified by it. When there is great impurity upon it, woe to it, suffering that punishment, for it is purified by fire twice. The first time, after the body receives its punishment, it is elevated to a place called Hinnom, 85R 90R 95R

[1] In the kabbalistic system, Malkhut (Kingdom) is the tenth and lowest sefirah, representing divine immanence in the created world. Its 'central point' refers to its essence or core that connects to higher divine attributes.

[2] In Kabbalah, Yesod (Foundation) is the ninth sefirah that channels divine flow into Malkhut. The souls are depicted as 'fruits' or emanations of this divine attribute, reflecting the kabbalistic view that human souls originate from and express different aspects of the divine structure.

[3] The four faces (lion, ox, eagle, and man) represent the four primary archetypes in the divine chariot described in Ezekiel's vision. In Kabbalah, they correspond to various divine attributes and cosmic forces that govern different aspects of creation.

[i] This is a reference to Exodus 33:23, where God tells Moses "you shall see My back, but My face shall not be seen." In kabbalistic interpretation, this describes the relationship between the male and female aspects of divinity, where the feminine aspect (Malkhut) receives from the "back" of the masculine aspect.

[ii] In kabbalistic terminology, "Daughter of Zion" represents the Shekhinah or divine feminine presence, which is identified with the sefirah of Malkhut (Kingdom), the lowest of the divine emanations and the channel through which divine influence flows to the created worlds.

[iii] This is a reference to the mystical concept of the River of Fire (nehar dinur) formed from the perspiration of the Chayot (living creatures) that bear God's throne. This river is mentioned in Daniel 7:10 and elaborated in mystical literature as a place where souls are purified.

[iv] The author employs a rabbinic logical principle of kal vachomer (a fortiori reasoning) using the

מאש אין מתלבן אותו לבוש
אלא באור וכן הנשמה היא מאש
הנמלת מתוך כסא הקדוש דכתיב
ביה כרסייה שביבין דנור. בעת
שרוצה להתלבן מזוהמא שבה
עוברת באש ומתרחצת והאש
אוכל כל זוהמא שבה ויש לה
צער כי ווי לנשמה שסובלת
אש נכרי[i] גם שהיא מתלבנת
בו וכשיש זוהמא רבה עליה
ווי לה הסובלת עונש ההוא
כי בשני פעמים מתלבנת באש.
פעם ראשון אחר שקבלה עונש
הגוף מעלים לה במקום הנקראת
הנום[ii] ששם מצרפים הנשמות
קודם בואן ליכנס בג״ע. אם
הנשמות ההם זוכות בשמכניסים
אותן למקום ההוא יש שני
ממונים והם מלאכים מזומנים
בג״ע ועומדים על השער
וצווחים לחותם ממונים של
גהינם לקבל אותה נשמה וקודם
שמתלבנת באור צווחים ואומרים
הנם ופעמים שמתלבנת ואותם
הממונים יוצאים עמה מן אותו
המקום ומזמנים לה לפתח גן עדן
ששם אותם השלוחים ואומרים
הנם ואז מכניסים אותה נשמה
בג״ע והיא משוברת מאש גהינם
שהוא שיבור אש תחתון[iii] אע״ג
שיורד מלמעלה ביון שמגיע

where souls are refined before entering the Garden of Eden. If those souls merit, when they are brought to that place, there are two appointed ones—angels stationed in the Garden of Eden who stand at the gate and call to those appointed over Gehenna to receive that soul. Before it is purified in the light, they call out saying, "Here they are!" Sometimes it is purified, and those appointed ones exit with it from that place and prepare for it the entrance to the Garden of Eden, where those messengers are, and they say, "Here they are!" Then they bring that soul into the Garden of Eden, broken from the fire of Gehenna,[1] which is the breaking of lower fire. Even though it descends from above, once it reaches the earth, it is a fire that is not so refined, and the soul is punished by it and broken. Then the Holy One, blessed be He, brings forth an illuminating sun from four openings that shine in the four sides of your Garden of Eden, reaching that soul and healing it. This is what is written: "But for you who fear My name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings."[2]

[1] Unlike many Western conceptions of hell as eternal punishment, the Jewish concept of Gehenna presented here is primarily purgatorial—a place where souls are painfully but ultimately beneficially purified of their accumulated spiritual impurities before entering the Garden of Eden.

[2] This concluding biblical quotation ties together the passage's theme of purification followed by healing. After souls undergo the painful but necessary cleansing in the fire of Gehenna, God provides healing illumination that restores and elevates them for their existence in the Garden of Eden.

mythological salamander, which was believed to be born from fire and immune to it. The argument is that if a salamander, being of fire, can be purified by fire without being consumed, then certainly a soul, which is also of a fiery nature, can undergo purification by fire without being destroyed.

[i] The term "foreign fire" (אש נכרי) alludes to the biblical concept of "strange fire" (אש זרה) from Leviticus 10:1, where Nadab and Abihu offered unauthorized fire before God and were consumed. Here it metaphorically refers to the purifying fire of Gehenna, which is foreign to the soul's divine essence.

[ii] Hinnom refers to the Valley of Hinnom (Gei Hinnom in Hebrew), which was historically a place where idolaters sacrificed children by fire. In rabbinic literature, it became associated with a purgatorial realm where souls are purified before entering the Garden of Eden, and is the origin of the term Gehenna.

[iii] The concept of "breaking of lower fire" refers to the kabbalistic idea that the divine light becomes increasingly materialized and "broken" or fragmented as it descends through the spiritual worlds.

לארץ הוא אש שאינו כל כך
דק ונשמה נענשת בו ומשתברת
ואז הקב״ה מוציא שמש המאיר
מארבע פתחים שמאירים בארבע
צדי גן עדך ומגיע על אותה
הנשמה ומתרפאת הדא הוא
דכתיב וזרחה לכם יראי שמי
שמש צדקה ומרפא בכנפיה:[i] [ii]

פרק ל״ז

אחר שנשמה זו ישבה בגן עדן
ועדיין לא אתפרשת מדברים
של עולם התחתון מכל וכל
כשמעלים אותה למעלה צריכה
לאתפרשא מכל דברים תחתונים
ומעבירים אותה פעם אחרת
באותו נהר דינור[iii] ומתלבנת
בו מכל וכל ומתראית לפני
בורא עולם מבורכת מכל

Chapter 37

After this soul has dwelled in the Garden of Eden but has not yet completely separated from the matters of the lower world,[1] when it is elevated higher,[A] it needs to separate from all lower matters. They pass it once more through that River of Fire (Nehar Dinur) where it is completely purified, and it appears before the Creator of the Universe blessed from all sides.[B] As it gazes upon that light, it is healed and perfected in every way. Thus the souls stand in adorned gar- 5R

[A] Or: "when they elevate it upward" — The Hebrew uses an active third-person plural form ('they elevate') rather than passive voice. This alternate translation preserves the sense that there are active spiritual agents (perhaps angels or other celestial beings) who facilitate the soul's ascension, rather than it being an automatic process.

[B] Or: "and it presents itself before the Creator of the Universe, blessed from every direction" — The Hebrew 'מכל הצדדין' literally means 'from all sides/directions.' This alternative conveys more precisely the multidimensional nature of the soul's blessed state after purification.

[1] The Hebrew 'לא אתפרשת מדברים של עולם התחתון מכל וכל' emphasizes total separation from worldly attachments. This reflects the kabbalistic belief that souls must progressively detach from physical existence to ascend to higher spiritual realms.

The fire of Gehenna, though originating from divine sources above, becomes less refined at lower levels and thus causes pain to the soul.

[i] This quotes Malachi 3:20 (4:2 in some translations): "But for you who fear My name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings." The author applies this verse to the divine healing light that restores souls after their painful purification in Gehenna.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The author is directly quoting and paraphrasing from the Zohar's mystical cosmology regarding the Garden of Eden and the afterlife journey of souls. The structure of heaven, the River of Fire (nehar dinur), and the process of soul purification are all core Zoharic concepts. | Cf. Isaiah 30:26 — The author cites this biblical verse to support the concept that souls damaged by the purification process in Gehenna are ultimately healed by divine light. This connects the biblical text to the kabbalistic concept of soul purification. | Cf. Genesis 3 — This refers to the biblical account of Adam's fall through the serpent's temptation, but reinterprets it in kabbalistic terms as disrupting the divine canopies and unifications that were prepared for him. | Cf. Ezekiel 1 — This draws from Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah), but integrates it into the structure of the Garden of Eden and the celestial realms that souls traverse after death. | Cf. Isaiah 4:5 — This alludes to Isaiah's prophecy about the future glory of Zion, but reinterprets it in kabbalistic terms as referring to the divine feminine (Malkhut/Shekhinah) and her adornments in the celestial realms.

[iii] The 'River of Fire' (Nehar Dinur) is a central concept in Jewish mystical literature, particularly in the Zohar. It represents a cosmic boundary between spiritual realms where souls are purified. According to kabbalistic tradition, all souls must pass through this river to cleanse themselves of worldly attachments before ascending to higher levels.

הצדדין ובהסתכלותה באותו האור מתרפאת ומשתלמת מכל וכל ובזה עומדים הנשמות בלבושים מעוטרים לפני האדון ה׳ צבאות שמו. ונשמות שבג״ע תחתון שאטין בכל ראש חדש ושבתות ומועדים ועולים עד המקום ההוא שנקרא חומות ירושלים[i] ששם כמה ממונים שומרי אותם החומות ואינם נכנסים לפנים עד שיתלבנו ושם משתחוים ושמחים מאור ההוא וחוזרים תוך הגן ויוצאים משם ושטות בעולם ורואים בפגרי האנשים הפושעים בי[ii] וגו׳ ואח״כ מסתכלים ובלי יסורין על יחוד שם שמים בתלמידים המתעניים בכל שני וחמישי וכדומה ובאים ואומרים למשיח והוא בוכה על רשעי ישראל כי הוא מחולל מפשעינו[iii] וכו׳ וחוזרים הנשמות למקומן. וכשיש רשעים הרבה שמורידים אותם לפני ולפנים במדורות גהינם האחרים[iv] ומקבלים עונש רב מרוב הזוהמא שבנשמותיהם אז מדליקים האש יותר לאכול אותו

ments[1] before the Lord, YHVH of Hosts is His name. 10R

The souls in the lower Garden of Eden roam about on every New Moon, Sabbath, and festival,[2] ascending to that place called the Walls of Jerusalem, where several appointed guardians watch over those walls. They do not enter within until they 15R are purified, and there they prostrate themselves and rejoice in that light, then return to the Garden. They depart from there and roam through the world, seeing "the corpses of the people who rebelled against Me," etc. Afterward, they observe those 20R who, without suffering, unify the Divine Name,[3] like students who fast every Monday and Thursday and the like. They come and tell the Messiah, who weeps over the wicked of Israel, for "he was wounded for our transgressions," etc., and the souls return to 25R their place.

When there are many wicked people who are brought down to the innermost chambers of Gehenna and receive great punishment due to the abundance of spiritual impurity in their souls, 30R then the fire is kindled more intensely to consume that impurity. Woe to the soul that endures that punishment! Fortunate are those who observe the commandments of the Torah.

When the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) wishes to 35R delight above—meaning to unify[A]—it is through the

[A] Or: "When the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) desires to take pleasure in the upper realms—which means to unite" — The Hebrew term 'להשתעשע' can be translated as 'delight,' 'take pleasure,' or 'enjoy.' Similarly, 'להתייחד' literally means 'to unite' or 'to become one,' which in mystical

[1] The concept of souls wearing 'garments' (לבושים/levushim) is important in Kabbalah. These spiritual vestments are formed from the person's Torah study and good deeds in life, and determine the soul's capacity to withstand and perceive divine light in the afterlife.

[2] The Hebrew 'שאטין' (roam/float) describes a form of spiritual movement specific to disembodied souls. The text emphasizes that souls have special mobility and privileges on sacred days in the Jewish calendar.

[3] This refers to those who achieve mystical unification (yichud) through spiritual disciplines like fasting, rather than through physical suffering. The unification of God's name is a central kabbalistic practice aimed at restoring cosmic harmony.

[i] In kabbalistic literature, 'the Walls of Jerusalem' represents a spiritual boundary between lower and higher realms of Paradise. This is not the physical Jerusalem but its celestial counterpart, which serves as a transition point for ascending souls.

[ii] This is a reference to Isaiah 66:24: 'And they shall go forth and look upon the corpses of the men who have transgressed against Me.' In this mystical context, it suggests that righteous souls witness the fate of the wicked as part of their afterlife experience.

[iii] This phrase quotes Isaiah 53:5: 'he was wounded for our transgressions.' The text applies this verse, traditionally associated with the 'suffering servant,' to the Messiah who bears the spiritual burden of Israel's sins.

[iv] According to kabbalistic tradition, Gehenna (Hell) contains multiple levels or chambers, with deeper levels corresponding to more severe punishment for greater spiritual corruption.

זוהמא ווי לאותה נשמה הסובלת
אותו העונש. אשרי שומרי
מצות התורה. השבינה כשהיא
רוצה להשתעשע למעלה[i] פירוש
להתייחד הוא על ידי רוחיהם
של צדיקים [ii]

spirits of the righteous.

כמה שנאמר וכשהיא רוצה
להשתעשע למטה ג״כ הוא
ברוחותיהם של צדיקים כאם
השמחה עם בניה ומשתעשעת
בהם[iii] וכן בחצות לילה
היא משתעשעת ומתייחדת
בהם. [iv] ברוזא קרי ופס ידא
כתבא כי אין בגן עדן אלא עסק
התורה כי הטוב שהוא השגת
האור הראשון אשר היתה יריעה
שנכתבו בו כל הנמצאות[v] והוא
לא יושג אלא על ידי התורה
שהעולם נברא בה ומהטוב ההוא
היה מוציא כל הנמצאות ואח״כ
השרישן בתורה והיינו וירא

As it is said, and when she [the Divine Presence] wishes to delight below,[1] it is also through the spirits of the righteous, like a mother rejoicing with her children and delighting in them. And so at midnight she delights and unites with them. The herald proclaims and the writing hand writes, for in the Garden of Eden there is nothing but the study of Torah, for the good—which is the attainment of the primordial light that was like a curtain on which all existences were inscribed[2]—can only be attained through Torah, with which the world was created. From that goodness, He brought forth all existences and afterward rooted them in the Torah. This is the meaning of "And God saw that it was good"—in the return of all things to their source, binding them

40R

45R

50R

contexts refers to the unification of divine aspects. This alternate translation emphasizes the pleasurable aspect of divine union rather than just the functional aspect.

[1] Here, 'she' refers to the Shekhinah or Divine Presence, which is portrayed with feminine imagery in Kabbalah. The vertical dimension (above and below) is central to kabbalistic cosmology, with divine delight flowing both in upper realms and downward into our world.

[2] This poetic description references the kabbalistic concept of the primordial Torah that preceded creation and served as its blueprint. The metaphor of a 'curtain' (yeri'ah) on which all of existence was written before being actualized is drawn from rabbinic sources.

[i] In kabbalistic terminology, 'delight' (שעשוע/sha'ashua) often refers to the mystical union of divine aspects. Here it specifically refers to the union of the Divine Presence with higher divine attributes through the medium of righteous souls.

[ii] Cf. Isaiah 66:24 — The text quotes Isaiah 66:24 which describes the fate of the wicked whose corpses will be viewed by the righteous. Here it is used to show how souls from Paradise observe the fate of sinners as part of their afterlife experience. | Cf. Isaiah 53:5 — The passage refers to Isaiah 53:5, applying it to the Messiah who weeps over Israel's wicked. This reflects the kabbalistic interpretation of the Messiah bearing Israel's spiritual suffering. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The concept of souls passing through the River of Fire for purification appears frequently in the Zohar, particularly in Vayakhel, where it describes how souls must be cleansed before ascending to higher spiritual realms. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Tractate Shabbat 152b — The Talmud discusses how souls have special privileges and movements on sacred days, which is elaborated in this kabbalistic framework of souls ascending to higher realms on these occasions.

[iii] This maternal metaphor for the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) is common in kabbalistic literature, portraying God's feminine aspect as nurturing and delighting in the righteous souls like a mother with her children.

[iv] Midnight is considered a particularly auspicious time in Kabbalah when the Divine Presence is most accessible. The Zohar frequently mentions that righteous individuals should rise at midnight for Torah study and prayer to participate in this cosmic union.

[v] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the Torah served as the blueprint for creation, with all existences first being inscribed in the primordial Torah before being actualized in the physical world.

אלהים כי טוב בחזרת הדברים
אל השורש וקשרן בתורה בכל
יום[i] ודרך כללן בכלל דכתיב
וירא אלהים את כל אשר עשה
והנה טוב מאד והתורה היא העדן
העליון[ii] והצדיקים מתעדנים
כפי מה שיפתחו בסודות התורה
כך הם מאירים באור עליון
ולכן התורה נקראת לקח טוב
כי הטוב צפון בה וכן בג״ע יש
עדן נקודה סתומה שהיא נובעת
לצדיקים סוד תורה[iii] ומתעדנים
שם מהעדן ההוא הסתום והטוב
תתפשט דרך אצילות בספירות
ומשם אל הנשמות בגן עדן עליון
בבריאה ומשם אל גן עדן תחתון
ביצירה[iv] ומשם אל העוה״ז
בגשמיות הזה. וזה עקר העבודה
בעוה״ז ויאכלו הצדיקים מפרי
דרכם בג״ע ויש לו לאדם בעוה״ז
לעורר הזווג עם כלל יושבי
הגן[v] [vi]

to the Torah each day. And He generally included them all, as it is written: "And God saw all that He had made, and behold, it was very good." The Torah is the supernal Eden,[1] and the righteous delight according to how much they uncover the secrets of the Torah—thus they shine with supernal light. Therefore, the Torah is called "good teaching" because goodness is stored within it. Similarly, in the Garden of Eden there is Eden, a hidden point that flows forth to the righteous the secret of Torah, and they delight there from that hidden Eden. And the goodness extends by way of emanation through the sefirot,[2] and from there to the souls in the upper Garden of Eden in the World of Creation,[3] and from there to the lower Garden of Eden in the World of Formation, and from there to this world in its physicality. This is the essence of divine service in this world, and the righteous eat from the fruit of their ways in the Garden of Eden. It is incumbent upon a person in this world to awaken the union with all the inhabitants of the Garden.[4]

55R 60R 65R 70R

[1] This identification of Torah with Eden itself, rather than merely a path to Eden, reflects the mystical notion that Torah study constitutes the highest spiritual pleasure. The word 'Eden' literally means 'delight' or 'pleasure' in Hebrew.

[2] The sefirot are the ten divine emanations or attributes through which God interacts with the world according to Kabbalah. They serve as channels through which divine goodness flows from its infinite source into increasingly material realms.

[3] This passage outlines a hierarchical cosmology where divine light descends through four worlds: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action, our physical world). Each world contains its own version of the Garden of Eden appropriate to souls at different spiritual levels.

[4] This 'union' (zivug) has mystical significance in Kabbalah, referring to the spiritual connection that can be created between living humans and the souls of the righteous in the Garden of Eden, particularly through Torah study and contemplative practices.

[i] This suggests the ongoing divine process where creation is continuously sustained by being bound to the Torah, not just a one-time creative act in the past.

[ii] This identifies the Torah itself with the supernal Eden, suggesting that Torah study is not merely a means to access Eden but is itself the highest form of spiritual delight.

[iii] This refers to the mystical dimensions or esoteric teachings of the Torah, beyond its literal meaning. In Kabbalah, these secrets are considered the highest level of Torah understanding.

[iv] The text describes a hierarchical structure of multiple Gardens of Eden corresponding to different spiritual worlds: the upper Garden in Beriah (World of Creation) and the lower Garden in Yetzirah (World of Formation).

[v] This refers to the kabbalistic practice of creating mystical unifications or connections with the souls of the righteous who dwell in the Garden of Eden, typically through prayer, study, and contemplative practices.

[vi] Cf. Zohar — This passage reflects classic Zoharic cosmology where the Divine Presence interacts with the souls of the righteous in the Garden of Eden, especially at midnight. The Zohar frequently describes the hierarchical structure of reality (four worlds: Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) that is mentioned here. | Cf. Genesis 1:31 — The author uses this verse to develop the kabbalistic concept that everything created was first inscribed in the Torah and then bound back to it, illus-

ובחינותיו ובפרט באליך ה׳
נפשי אשא[i] כדכתיב ברכו ה׳
כל מלאכיו וכל צבאיו ואח״כ
ברכי נפשי כי בזה יזכה שבחצות
יבא הקב״ה להשתעשע ליטול
התעוררות מנשמתו אחרי מותו
בג״ע. והנה בגן בו באימת רבות
מתפשטות לכמה מציאיות[ii] ואין
כל צדיק מתפשט בכלו אלא
כפי הרשות הניתן לו והצדיקים
מתהלכים ומתעדנים בו עד
שהם מתהלכים אל סוד נקודה
האמצעית[iii] ששם סוד העדן
והשפעה לכל הגן יוצאת מאותה
נקודה האמצעית ומשתעשעים
בהשכלת ענייני הגן ונטיעותיו
עד שמגיעים אל סוד נקודת העדן
שמשם אורה והשפעה יוצאת לכל
הגן להאירו ולצחצחו ושם
עומדים האבים להשכיל בסוד
הנקודה ושם הם נעשים אשד
נהר הברכה המשקה ושם עקר
מעמד האדם כדכתיב וכל שיח
השדה וגו׳ בגין דאדם אין.
א״כ אדם עקר אשר על הברכה
באותה נקודה האמצעית. וקול
ה׳ אלהים מתהלך בגן לרוח
היום היינו סוד אותה הנקודה
אשר בגן שאותו העדן מכוון
נגדו להמשיך שם נהרי ההשפעה
ושם עקר התהלכות האדם
כדי להעלות סוד התעוררות
אל יחוד העדן בינה עם הגן

and its aspects, particularly in "To You, O LORD, I lift up my soul," as it is written, "Bless the LORD, all His angels, all His hosts," and afterward, "Bless the LORD, O my soul." For through this, one merits that at midnight the Holy One, blessed be He, comes to delight and take awakening from his soul after his death in the Garden of Eden. And behold, in the garden, with great awe,[1] many realities extend, and not every righteous person extends through all of it, but only according to the permission granted to him. The righteous walk about and delight in it until they walk to the secret of the central point, where the secret of Eden is, and influence for the entire garden flows from that central point. They delight in contemplating the matters of the garden and its plantings until they reach the secret of the point of Eden, from which light and influence emanate to the entire garden to illuminate and refine it. There they stand, yearning to comprehend the secret of the point, and there they become the waterfall of the river of blessing that waters, and there is the essential station of man, as it is written, "and every plant of the field," etc., "because there was no man." Thus, man is essentially established over the blessing at that central point.

75R 80R 85R 90R 95R

And "the voice of the LORD God walking in the garden in the cool of the day" refers to the secret of that point in the garden, which that Eden is directed toward to draw there the rivers of influence. There is the essential walking of man in order to raise the secret of awakening to the unification of Eden (Binah) with the garden (the six extremities), from which it divides into four heads of watches: the morning

100R 105R

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'באימת רבות' is challenging to translate precisely. It could also be rendered as 'with many fears/reverence' or 'with the awe of the many.' I've chosen to interpret it as describing the awesome or fearful experience of encountering divine realities in the Garden of Eden.

trating the Torah's central role in both creation and the souls' afterlife experience. | Cf. Proverbs 4:2 — The author draws on this biblical description of Torah as 'lekach tov' (good teaching) to connect it with the primordial goodness/light mentioned earlier, suggesting that the Torah contains and preserves this divine goodness. | Cf. Tikunei Zohar — This section echoes the Tikunei Zohar's detailed explanations of how divine influx descends through the four worlds (Atzilut/Emanation, Beriah/Creation, Yetzirah/Formation, Asiyah/Action), with souls experiencing different levels of Eden corresponding to these worlds.

[i] This phrase from Psalm 25:1 ("To You, O LORD, I lift up my soul") is interpreted here as a mystical practice for soul elevation and divine connection.

[ii] This describes the Garden of Eden as containing multiple mystical realities or dimensions that extend outward from a central point, reflecting the kabbalistic concept of divine emanation.

[iii] The 'central point' is a key kabbalistic concept representing the mystical center from which divine influence emanates throughout all realms of existence.

שש קצוות[i] שמשם יפרד לד׳
ראשי משמרות משמרת הבקר
מיכאל וכו׳ וכמה פעמים נשמע
בג״ע קול ה׳ אלהים כדאמרו
בזוהר חבירין אתכנשו ליחדא
האי איילתא כי קוראים על
נטיעות הגן והענפים כלם ליקשר
אל היחוד. ויחוד הצדיקים
הוא במה שהם נכללים באור
הספירות והם ב׳ מיני יחוד
א׳ בג״ע של מעלה הב׳ בג״ע
של מטה[ii] הצדיקים מתלבשים
באויר ג״ע בסוד ומרדכי יצא
מלפני המלך בלבוש מלכות
כי הצדיקים מתלבשים באויר
ג״ע אור מדת מלכות ואחר כך
אור הת״ת מאיר באויר גן עדן
ומאיר סוד לבושי הצדיקים וזהו
ג״כ סוד לבושי הצדיקים בגן
עדן של מעלה שהם שם בפלא
גדול הנשמות זכות וטהורות
לא כדמות גוף וגויה אלא שכל
זך מתלבשות בשכל נפלא אור
השכינה ואח״כ שכל הספירה
העליונה שהיא ת״ת משכלת
בהם ויתקשרו הספירות בסוד
הנשמות המתקשרות ומתלבשות
באור הספירות ומעין זה היה
ממש יחוד הספירות בימי אדם
בהיותו בסוד כתנות אור[iii] והיה
ממש לבוש באור השכינה עומד
ומצפה מתי יבא אור הת״ת ומאיר
בו ויתייחד קוב״ה ושכינתיה
באור אור לבושו ואופן היחוד

watch is Michael, etc. And many times in the Garden of Eden the voice of the LORD God is heard, as they said in the Zohar, "Beloved ones, gather to unify this hind," for they call upon the plantings of the garden and all the branches to bind to the unification. 110R

The unification of the righteous is in how they are included in the light of the sefirot, and there are two types of unification: one in the Garden of Eden above, and the second in the Garden of Eden below. The righteous are clothed in the atmosphere of the Garden of Eden, in the secret of "and Mordecai went out from before the king in royal garments," for the righteous are clothed in the atmosphere of the Garden of Eden with the light of the attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom). Afterward, the light of Tiferet (Beauty) illuminates the atmosphere of the Garden of Eden and illuminates the secret of the garments of the righteous.[1] This is also the secret of the garments of the righteous in the Garden of Eden above, where they exist in great wonder. The souls are pure and clean, not in the likeness of body and physical form, but rather as purified intellect clothed in wondrous intellect,[2] the light of the Divine Presence. Then the intellect of the supreme sefirah, which is Tiferet, comprehends them, and the sefirot are bound in the secret of the souls that are connected and clothed in the light of the sefirot. 115R 120R 125R 130R

Similar to this was the actual unification of the sefirot in the days of Adam when he existed in the secret of "garments of light" and was actually clothed in the light of the Divine Presence, standing and waiting for when the light of Tiferet would come and illuminate him. Then the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence would be unified in the light 135R 140R

[1] The text presents a complex mystical process where righteous souls receive illumination first from Malkhut (Kingdom) and then from Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), representing a progressive integration with divine attributes after death.

[2] This passage describes the non-physical nature of souls in the Garden of Eden, emphasizing their purely intellectual or spiritual nature, free from bodily form but still possessing a kind of 'garment' or vehicle for expression.

[i] This describes the mystical unification between Binah (Understanding, the third sefirah) and the 'six extremities' (the six lower sefirot from Chesed to Yesod), representing the joining of higher and lower divine attributes.

[ii] The text distinguishes between two types of mystical unification experienced by righteous souls: one in the upper Garden of Eden (associated with higher divine realms) and one in the lower Garden of Eden (closer to our physical realm).

[iii] This refers to the 'garments of light' that Adam and Eve wore before the Fall, according to rabbinic interpretation. The biblical text in Genesis 3:21 mentions 'garments of skin' (כתנות עור), but a mystical reading suggests the original state was 'garments of light' (כתנות אור), differing only by the letter aleph.

הנעשה בלבוש הזה עתה אין
באן מקומו רק שאנו מוסרים
נפשותינו שם בסוד אליך ה׳
נפשי אשא. ואינו מגיע לנו אלא
ניצוץ נעלם מלבוש בעלי היחוד
כדכתיב ורוח לבשה את עמשי
ורוח לבשה את שמעיה ורוח
לבשה את זכריה וכדומה. וזה
נעלם ובלתי מושג בלבוש הזה.
ולבוש זה יתוקן בתחיה[i] כי
יעמדו הגופים גופי עור ויתהפכו
לאור ויתקיים בו במקום שבעלי
תשובה עומדים וכו׳ כי יזדכך
גם לבוש זה והדרוש הזה רחב
מאד במקומו. כי מה שאפילו
עתה רע הכל יתהפך לטוב. [ii]

of his garment. The manner of unification that occurs in this garment—this is not the place to discuss it now, except that we deliver our souls there in the secret of "To You, O LORD, I lift up my soul." And what reaches us is only a hidden spark[1] clothed in those who achieve unification, as it is written, "And a spirit clothed Amasai," "And a spirit clothed Shemaiah," "And a spirit clothed Zechariah," and the like. And this is hidden and unattainable in this garment. This garment will be rectified in the resurrection, for the bodies, bodies of skin, will arise and be transformed into light. And it will be fulfilled that "in the place where penitents stand,"[2] etc., for this garment too will be purified. This subject is very broad in its proper place. For what is even now evil will all be transformed to good.[3]

פרק ל״ח

Chapter 38

נחזור לדבר על דבר הרקיע
אשר זכרנו למעלה. רקיע שעל

Let us return to discuss the firmament which we mentioned above. The firmament above the garden is be-

[1]The text suggests that living humans can only experience a small 'spark' of the divine unification that righteous souls experience in the Garden of Eden, through moments of spiritual inspiration like those described in biblical verses about the spirit 'clothing' certain individuals.
[2]This is an allusion to a Talmudic teaching (Berakhot 34b) that 'In the place where penitents (ba'alei teshuvah) stand, even the completely righteous cannot stand,' suggesting that transformed bodies at resurrection will achieve an even higher spiritual status than their original state.
[3]This concluding statement reflects the optimistic eschatology of Jewish mysticism, suggesting that the ultimate purpose of creation is the transformation of all evil into good, a process that begins with individual spiritual practice and culminates in the resurrection.

[i]This refers to the Jewish belief in resurrection (techiyat ha-metim), when the author suggests that physical bodies will be transformed back into spiritual 'garments of light.'
[ii]Cf. Psalm 25:1 — The text interprets this psalm as a mechanism for mystical unification with divine attributes, suggesting that properly reciting this prayer facilitates the soul's elevation both in life and after death | Cf. Psalm 103:20-22 — This sequence is interpreted mystically as a pattern for spiritual ascension, suggesting that by following this order in prayer, humans can join with angelic hosts in unified divine service | Cf. Zohar on Song of Songs — This Zohar quote is used to illustrate how in the Garden of Eden, souls participate in the cosmic unification of divine attributes, particularly joining together to elevate the Divine Feminine | Cf. Genesis 2:5 — The text reinterprets this verse mystically to suggest that the 'absence of man' refers to the central position of human souls as connectors between divine realms | Cf. Genesis 3:8 — The text interprets this verse mystically to describe how divine influence emanates from a central point in the Garden of Eden that serves as a conduit between higher and lower realms | Cf. Book of Esther 8:15 — This historical narrative is reinterpreted mystically to represent how righteous souls are 'clothed' in the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom) in the Garden of Eden | Cf. Genesis 3:21 — The text refers to a rabbinic interpretation that before sin, Adam and Eve wore 'garments of light' rather than skin, using this to explain the mystical state of souls before the resurrection | Cf. 1 Chronicles 12:18 — This verse and similar ones about Shemaiah and Zechariah are used to illustrate the rare phenomenon of divine spirit 'clothing' or enveloping certain individuals, which the text suggests is a glimpse of the soul's future state after resurrection | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 34b — The text applies this teaching to the resurrection, suggesting that just as repentant sinners stand higher than the completely righteous, bodies transformed from 'skin' to 'light' will achieve an elevated spiritual status

הגן הוא למטה ויש עוד רקיע
של הנקודה העליונה העומד
על ארבע חיות גדולות[i] וכל
חיילות תחתונות מצפות מזונם
מההוא רקיע ובו ארבע פתחים
רשומים באותיות ההוי״ה
המאירים ומהם יורד טל לזון
כל חיילות ומחנות קדושות
וכל חיילות תחתונים מעלים
שירות ותושבחות בסיבוב רקיע
עליון זה ואומרים בקול נעים
ברוך כבוד ה׳ ממקומו ומתייחד
ה׳ אלהים ובו רשומים כמה
אותיות וכמה שמות הקדש
וממנו מקבלים כל הרקיעים
שלמטה שהם לצד הקדושה
עד שמגיעים לרקיעים אחרים
של סטרא אחרא הנקראים
יריעות עזים.[ii] העליונים
הם בסוד מרכבות עליונות
קדושות ואלה אחרים עומדים
לחוץ בדבריהעולם והם צדדין
של מעשי הגוף וחופים על
הרקיעים שבפנים כקליפה על
המוח.[iii] התחתונים נקראים
שמים והעליונים השמים שמים
לה׳. מכאן ולהלאה אין מי
שיוכל לידע רק אור קטן בלתי
אפשר להתקיים בו והכי חמרו
באדרא דנשא עדן דלעיל ליתמאן דידע ליה ולא שבלויי בר
ההוא אריך אנפין[iv] הדא הוא
דכתיב אלהים הבין דרכה והוא
ידע את מקומה. וגם שגבהו

low, and there is another firmament of the supernal point that stands upon four great celestial creatures. All the lower hosts await their sustenance from this 5R
firmament, which has four openings inscribed with the four letters of the divine name YHVH[1] that illuminate. From these openings descends dew to nourish all the hosts and holy camps. All the lower hosts offer songs and praises as they encircle this upper fir- 10R
mament, saying in a pleasant voice,[2] "Blessed is the glory of the LORD from His place," and thus "the LORD God" becomes unified. Upon it are inscribed many letters and many holy names, and from it all the lower firmaments receive—those that are on the 15R
side of holiness—until they reach other firmaments of the Other Side, called "curtains of goats' hair." The upper ones exist as holy celestial chariots, while these others stand outside in worldly matters, representing aspects of bodily actions, and cover the inner firma- 20R
ments like a shell over the brain. The lower ones are called "heavens," and the upper ones "the heavens of heavens unto the LORD."

Beyond this point, no one can know more than a small light in which it is impossible to exist, as they 25R
explained in the Idra of Nasso: "The Eden above—there is none who knows it or its paths except for that Long-Faced One (Arich Anpin)," as it is written, "God understands its way, and He knows its place." Even though His ways are elevated to the heights 30R
of the universe, there is still some evidence for our inquiry: "Happy are those who dwell in Your house; they will continue to praise You, Selah."

From the words of the Zohar at the beginning of Parashat Yitro, pages 42-43, it appears that be- 35R
sides the dwelling place of the Court of Death for

[1] The Hebrew text uses the term ההוי״ה, which is a conventional way of referring to the four-letter divine name (Tetragrammaton) without pronouncing it directly. This name is considered most sacred in Jewish tradition.

[2] This references the angelic praise from Ezekiel 3:12, which is incorporated in Jewish liturgy, particularly in the Kedushah prayer during the repetition of the Amidah.

[i] This refers to the four celestial creatures from Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah), which are often depicted as having faces of a man, lion, ox, and eagle.

[ii] The 'Other Side' (Sitra Achra) refers to forces of impurity or evil in Kabbalistic thought. The metaphor of 'curtains of goats' hair' alludes to the coverings of the Tabernacle in Exodus 26:7, here repurposed as a metaphor for spiritual barriers.

[iii] This metaphor of shell (kelipah) and brain (moach) is central to Kabbalistic thought, where shells or husks represent barriers that conceal divine light (the 'brain' or inner essence).

[iv] Arich Anpin ('Long Face' or 'Long-Suffering') is a divine configuration in Kabbalah representing God's aspect of infinite patience and mercy, often associated with the divine attribute of Keter (Crown).

דרכיו ברומו של עולם מ״מ קצת
ראיה הוא על הדרוש שאנו בו
אשרי יושבי ביתך עוד יהללוך
40 סלה. מדברי הזהר ריש פ׳ יתרו
דף מ״ב ומ״ג נראה שמלבד מדור
חצר מות לנפש וג״ע תחתון לרוח
וג״ע עליון ללשמה וצרורא
דחיי למעלה שכל מדרגות אלו
45 הם בעולם הנשמות שהוא אחר
המות יש עוד עולם הבא שהוא
אחר התחיה כדברי הרמב״ן
בשער הגמול. ומלבד זה יש עוד
מעלה אחרת עליונה שהיא ביתא
50 עילאה קדישא דזכאה חולקיה
דההוא דמדוריה עם מלכא
בביתיה ועליו נאמר אז תתענג
על ה׳[i] ואמר כי ביתא דא נקרא
אי״ן[ii] ע״ש. ובטול הקליפה תלוי
55 בתחיה דאז נהירו ינהר בעלמא
בלא סתימו מגו מוחא כן כתוב
בפ׳ יתרו דף ס״ט ע״ב וכבר
דברנו מזה למעלה. וכתוב
בסבא דף ק״ח ע״ב דבבנין בית
60 המקדש העתיד יקדים מוחא
דכתיב הטיבה ברצונך את ציון
בקדמותא ולבתר תבנה חומות
ירושלם[iii] דלא יהיו מסטרא
דקליפא רק מצד הקדושה
65 דכתיב ואני אהיה לה חומת
אש סביב וזהו ראו עתה כי
אני אני הוא ואין אלהים עמדי
בקדמת דנא דעם אנ״י ה׳ למטה
אלהים אחרים עו״ג. אני אמית

the nefesh (vital soul), the lower Garden of Eden for the ruach (spirit), the upper Garden of Eden for the neshamah (higher soul), and the Bond of Life above—all these levels existing in the World of Souls after death—there is also the World to Come, which is after the resurrection, as Nachmanides writes in Sha'ar HaGemul. Beyond this, there is yet another higher level,[1] which is the holy supernal house, and fortunate is the portion of one whose dwelling is with the King in His house. Of this it is said, "Then you shall delight yourself in the LORD," and it is said that "this house is called 'Ayin' (Nothingness)."[2]

The nullification of the shell (kelipah) depends on the resurrection, for then light will shine in the world without being concealed from within the brain, as is written in Parashat Yitro, page 69b, and we have already discussed this above. And it is written in Saba, page 108b, that in the building of the future Temple, the brain will come first, as it is written, "Do good in Your favor unto Zion" at first, and afterward "build the walls of Jerusalem," which will not be from the side of the shell but from the side of holiness,[3] as it is written, "And I will be unto her a wall of fire round about." This is the meaning of "See now that I, even I, am He, and there is no god with Me," unlike before when alongside "ANI" (I) the LORD, below were "other gods" (idolatry). "I kill and I make alive"—those who will exist at that time and have not tasted the taste of death will nevertheless experience death, and He will resurrect them immediately, so that no impurity will remain at all, and the world will be renewed.

Each righteous person increases in stature in

40R 45R 50R 55R 60R 65R

[1]The text is describing a spiritual cosmology with multiple levels of afterlife experience, each more elevated than the previous. This highest level transcends even the World to Come after resurrection.

[2]The paradoxical concept of 'Ayin' (nothingness) as the highest divine realm is central to Kabbalistic thought, particularly in the school of Isaac Luria. It represents transcendence beyond all comprehensible attributes.

[3]The author is describing a transformation where the boundaries between holiness and impurity (represented by walls) will no longer function as barriers but will themselves become holy—transformed from physical limitations into divine protection.

[i]This is a quote from Isaiah 58:14, which in its original context refers to delighting in God through proper observance of the Sabbath. Here it is reinterpreted as referring to the ultimate spiritual delight in the highest level of the World to Come.

[ii]The term 'Ayin' (literally 'nothing' or 'nothingness') in Kabbalah paradoxically refers to the highest divine realm that transcends human comprehension, associated with the sefirah of Keter (Crown).

[iii]This comes from Psalm 51:20, but the author interprets it mystically to describe the future spiritual rebuilding of Jerusalem with walls of divine fire rather than physical barriers.

ואחיה[i] דמאן דהוו בההוא זמנא דלא טעמו טעמא דמותא מינה תהא לון מיתה ויקים להו מיד בגין דלא אשתאר מההיא זוהמא כלל ויחודש העולם. וכל צדיק וצדיק מוסיף במעלתו בעה״ב דאמרי׳ בשבת שלכל צדיק עושין לו מדור לפי כבודו ובסוף מס׳ תענית עתיד הקב״ה לעשות מחול לצדיקים בג״ע וכו׳ בפ׳ קמא דמגילה עתיד הקב״ה להיות עטרה בראש כל צדיק וכו׳ ובפ׳ המוכר את הספינה אמר משבעה חופות שיש לכל צדיק בג״ע וכל הנביאים לא נתנבאו אלא לימות המשיח כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ אין עומדים אבל לעה״ב וכו׳ והקפואים בעה״ז יקרים הם לעה״ב כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ אלו עוברין. וכתב בעל יפה מראה בדף ע״ח כי לעולם הצדיקים מוסיפין והולכים תמיד אחרי מותם ואמרו בקהלת רבתי כל מי שהוא יגע בתורה בעה״ז מוליכים אותו לבית מדרשו של שם ועבר ושל אברהם יצחק ויעקב ומשה ואהרן וכו׳ עד ועשיתי לך שם כשם הגדולים אשר בארץ. ובשוחר טוב מזמור פ״ד אין נחת רוח לחברים לעולם עד היכן עד יראה אל אלהים בציון ע״ד שאמרו בגמרין צדיקים אין להם מנוחה וכו׳ כפרש״י מג״ע לפרגוד ומפרגוד למחנה שבינה שנאמר ילכו מחיל אל חיל. ואחר התחיה אז יהיה עקר השגת עץ החיים ויזכו כלם לכתנות אור כי נשמות הצדיקים

the World to Come, as we say in Tractate Shabbat that for each righteous person, a dwelling place is made according to his honor. At the end of Tractate Ta'anit: "The Holy One, blessed be He, will make a circle for the righteous in the Garden of Eden," etc. In the first chapter of Megillah: "The Holy One, blessed be He, will be a crown on the head of every righteous person," etc. And in the chapter "The Seller of the Ship," it speaks of seven canopies that exist for every righteous person[1] in the Garden of Eden. All the prophets prophesied only about the days of the Messiah, as we say in the chapter "Ein Omdin," but regarding the World to Come, etc. Those who are deprived in this world will be precious in the World to Come, as we say in the chapter "Elu Ovrin."

The author of Yefeh Mareh writes on page 78 that the righteous continuously progress and advance after their death. And it is said in Kohelet Rabbati that whoever toils in Torah in this world is led to the academy of Shem and Ever, and of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and Moses and Aaron, etc., until "I will make for you a name like the name of the great ones who are in the earth." And in Midrash Shocher Tov, Psalm 84, "There is no contentment for the companions forever—until when? Until 'they appear before God in Zion,'" following what they said in our Gemara: "The righteous have no rest," etc., as Rashi explains: from the Garden of Eden to the curtain, and from the curtain to the camp of the Divine Presence,[2] as it is said, "They go from strength to strength."

After the resurrection, the primary attainment will be of the Tree of Life, and all will merit garments of light, for the souls of the righteous in the Garden of Eden enjoy the Tree of Life—some reach out with a hand alone, some take, and some eat,[3] each according to his measure that he achieved in this world.

[1] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Bava Batra 75a) that in the World to Come, each righteous person will have seven celestial canopies made from clouds of glory, based on Isaiah 4:5.

[2] This describes the continuous spiritual ascension of righteous souls, moving from one celestial realm to another. The 'curtain' (pargod) refers to the mystical veil separating the Divine Presence from lower realms.

[3] This metaphorical language describes different levels of spiritual attainment and comprehension of divine mysteries, with 'eating' representing the most complete absorption of divine wisdom.

[i] This quote from Deuteronomy 32:39 is interpreted here to mean that even those who survive until the messianic era will still experience death and immediate resurrection to ensure complete purification from spiritual impurity.

בג״ע נהנים מעץ החיים יש שולח
יד לבדו יש לוקח ויש אוכל כל
110 אחד לפי שעורו שעשה בעה״ז
אמנם אחר התחיה יתחדש העולם
בכח החיים העתידים בסוד
עולמו של יובל כי עסק התורה
שיהיה אחר התחיה יהיה בסודות
115 הנעלמות[i] אשר עדיין לא נתגלו
בעולם וכפי אותו עסק ירויחו
העה״ב ואותו העה״ב יהיה יותר
רוחני כלומר בלי התלבשות
אמא עלאה דמקננא בכורסיא
120 אלא בעה״ב העליון ממש הבינה
בעצמה בלי מסכים. וזהו סוד
בשנת היובל הזאת תשובו איש
אל אחוזתו.[ii] וכמו שאמרנו
למעלה כי בעה״ז עוסק האדם
125 במצות מעשיות ובפשטי התורה
וסודותיה אשר נתנו לידרש
בעה״ז ומתוכם יזכה לסודות
המתגלים בג״ע עליון ותחתון
שהם התעוררות אורות הבריאה
130 כמו כן תהיה התחיה הבנה
לעה״ב כנזכר מלבד כי העה״ב
אחר התחיה יהיה בגוף ונפש כי
יזדכך כל כך הגוף בטל התחיה
שיהיה רוחני כנשמה[iii] ובאותו
135 עסק התורה והמצות שיעסוק
בזמן הזה יזכה ליכנס בעוה״ב
בגוף ונפש ובזה לא יקפח הקב״ה
שכר הגוף שעסק בעה״ז:[iv]

However, after the resurrection, the world will be renewed with the power of the future lives in the secret of the world of Jubilee, for the study of Torah after the resurrection will concern hidden mysteries that have not yet been revealed in the world. According to that study, they will profit in the World to Come, and that World to Come will be more spiritual, meaning without the enclothement of the supernal Mother who nests in the Throne, but in the truly higher World to Come—Binah itself without veils.[1] This is the secret of "In this year of Jubilee you shall return, each man to his possession." 110R 115R

As we said above, in this world a person engages in practical commandments and in the plain meanings of the Torah and its mysteries that were given to be expounded in this world. Through these, one merits the mysteries revealed in the upper and lower Garden of Eden, which are the awakening of the lights of Creation. Similarly, the resurrection will be a preparation for the World to Come, as mentioned, except that the World to Come after the resurrection will involve both body and soul, for the body will be so purified by the dew of resurrection that it will be spiritual like the soul. And through that engagement in Torah and commandments in which one engages in this time, one will merit to enter the World to Come with body and soul. In this way, the Holy One, blessed be He, will not deprive the body of its reward[2] for its efforts in this world. 120R 125R 130R 135R

[1] Binah (Understanding) is the third of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) in Kabbalah. The text suggests that in the highest World to Come, souls will experience this divine attribute directly, without the mediating 'veils' that normally separate humanity from direct divine experience.

[2] This addresses a theological question about bodily resurrection: if spiritual existence is superior, why resurrect bodies at all? The answer given is that the body deserves reward for its participation in fulfilling commandments during earthly life.

[i] The text suggests that Torah study after resurrection will involve mystical dimensions not yet revealed in our world, indicating a progressive revelation of divine wisdom across cosmic history.

[ii] This verse from Leviticus 25:13 about the Jubilee year (when ancestral lands were returned to their original owners) is interpreted mystically as referring to souls returning to their divine source in the World to Come.

[iii] The concept of 'dew of resurrection' (tal ha-techiyah) appears in rabbinic literature as the mystical substance that will resurrect the dead. Here it is described as having transformative properties that spiritualize the physical body.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Yitro, pages 42-43 — This reference establishes the hierarchical structure of the soul's journey after death through multiple celestial realms, providing the foundational cosmology that the current text elaborates upon. | Cf. Ramban (Nachmanides), Sha'ar HaGemul — The author cites Nachmanides to support the distinction between the intermediate state of disembodied souls in Gan Eden and the ultimate World to Come following resurrection, establishing a multi-

פרק ל״ט

Chapter 39

מלבד הנדרש בפרקים הקודמים מהצירוף שהתקין אלהינו מרחם לנפשות ורוחות ונשמות לבל ידח מהם נדח עוד בפרק זה נשוב להוסיף בו מה שהורונו מזה חכמינו ז״ל וההוגה בו ימצא איזה חדוש כאשר עשינו בדרושי ג״ע ברחמי שמים. אמרו בבראשית רבה כי האדים העולים מן השמים ומן הארץ הם נפשות הנדחים וכתב הראב״ד בהקדמתו לספר יצירה בדף ח׳ שהם עצמם מתפעלים להיות באוצרות שלג ואוצרות ברד[i] ובהם נפרע הקב״ה מן הרשעים שנאמר אשר חשכתי לעת צר ליום קרב ומלחמה כי באבני ברד נפרע מפרעה ומאנשי ארץ ישראל בימי יהושע וכן בכל יום נידונים הרשעים מאש לשלג ומשלג לאש וכן התמורות וכן הובא בירו׳ בפ׳ חלק וכאשר יתמו עונם יחזרו להיות אפר הרומז למלכות תחת כפות רגלי הצדיקים יסוד וזהו כי לשלג יאמר הוה ארץ. ותרגום

Beyond what was discussed in the previous chapters about the arrangement our God mercifully prepared for souls, spirits, and higher souls so that none of them would be cast away, in this chapter we will add what our Sages of blessed memory taught us about this. The reader will find some novel insights, as we did in our discussions of the Garden of Eden, with the help of Heaven. They said in Bereishit Rabbah that the vapors rising from the heavens and from the earth are the souls of those who have been cast away.[1] The RABD (Rabbi Abraham ben David) wrote in his introduction to Sefer Yetzirah on page 8 that these very souls are transformed to exist in the storehouses of snow and storehouses of hail, through which the Holy One, blessed be He, punishes the wicked, as it is said: "Which I have reserved for the time of trouble, for the day of battle and war" (Job 38:23). For with hailstones He punished Pharaoh and the people of the land of Israel in the days of Joshua. And so every day the wicked are judged, from fire to snow and from snow to fire,[2] and so are the transformations. This is also brought in the Jerusalem Talmud in chapter Chelek. And when their iniquity is complete, they will return to become ashes, which alludes to Malkhut (Kingdom) beneath the feet of the righteous ones,[3] which is Yesod (Foundation).

[1] The concept of 'souls of the cast away' (נפשות הנדחים) is a complex kabbalistic idea referring to souls that have been separated from their divine source due to sin. These souls are seen as existing in a state of spiritual exile, transformed into elemental forces used for divine punishment.

[2] This description of the wicked being judged through alternating extremes of fire and snow represents the kabbalistic understanding of purification through opposites. The soul must experience contrary states to be cleansed of impurity before it can be reintegrated into the divine order.

[3] This refers to the mystical hierarchy of souls in the afterlife, where the righteous stand above (spiritually superior to) the wicked. The metaphor of the wicked becoming ashes under the feet

stage afterlife cosmology. | Cf. Zohar, Idra of Nasso — The citation establishes the epistemic humility required when discussing the highest celestial realms, noting that only Arich Anpin (a divine configuration) has access to the highest Eden. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Yitro, page 69b — The reference supports the text's claim that at resurrection, the spiritual 'shells' or barriers will be eliminated, allowing unmediated divine illumination to permeate the world. | Cf. Talmudic tractates—Shabbat, Ta'anit, Megillah, and Bava Batra (The Seller of the Ship) — These Talmudic citations collectively establish the traditional rabbinic understanding of the World to Come as including both spiritual and quasi-physical rewards for the righteous, which the author incorporates into his kabbalistic cosmology. | Cf. Kohelet Rabbati — This reference supports the text's conception of ongoing spiritual progress after death, with scholars continuing their studies in celestial academies led by biblical figures. | Cf. Psalm 84, as interpreted in Midrash Shocher Tov — This reference reinforces the text's view that souls don't remain static after death but continue ascending through spiritual realms, 'from strength to strength' as the psalm states.

[i] The 'storehouses of snow and hail' reference comes from Job 38:22, where God asks Job if he has seen these divine storehouses, establishing them as cosmic repositories of divine power.

אשר חשכתי וגו׳ די גנזית תלגא נעידן עקתא בגיהנם וברדא ליום קרבא דפרעה. ואמר הראב״ד שם כי יש שני מיני שלג[i] יעויין [ii] שם.

This is the meaning of "For to the snow He says, 'Fall on the earth'" (Job 37:6). And the translation of "Which I have reserved..." is "that I have stored snow for the time of distress in Gehenna, and hail for the day of battle with Pharaoh." And the RABD says there that there are two types of snow, see there for details.

ואיך גהינם מתהוה אחר המות לראויים אליו הוא כי צער החולי נדבק בו מיום אשר הנפש בחול עליו[iii] וחום החולי חוזר להיות חומר לחום האש היסודי אשר בצאת הנפש מגוף החולה תגיע ליסוד האש בכח הדמיון אשר הגיע לה מצער החולי וחומו[iv] וחנה האש היסודי נדבק בנפש ההיא ונוסף חום על חומה עד שיגיע אליה האש היורד מן נהר דינור ותחול על האש ההיא ועוד ירד עליה סערת ה׳ חמה וסער מתגורר על ראש רשעים יחול והוא הדין למת מקרירות שיתחבר אליו דינים ושפטים

How Gehenna forms after death for those deserving it: The pain of illness adheres to a person from the day the soul falls ill, and the heat of the illness transforms into material for the elemental fire. When the soul departs from the sick person's body, it reaches the element of fire through the power of imagination that it acquired from the suffering and heat of the illness. The elemental fire then adheres to that soul, and heat is added to its heat until it is reached by the fire descending from the River of Dinur,[1] which settles upon that fire. Additionally, "the storm of the LORD, wrath has gone forth, a whirling tempest; it will whirl upon the head of the wicked" (Jeremiah 23:19). The same principle applies to one who dies from cold conditions—judgments and punishments from snow and hail will attach to him.

of the righteous represents their total spiritual subjugation and the triumph of good over evil in the cosmic order.

[1] The River of Dinur (or River of Fire) appears in Daniel 7:10 and features prominently in rabbinic and mystical literature as a celestial river of fire where angels are purified and through which souls must pass after death.

[i] The RABD (Rabbi Abraham ben David) discusses two types of mystical snow, likely referring to different levels or qualities of divine judgment. This reflects the kabbalistic tendency to perceive dual aspects within cosmic forces.

[ii] Cf. Book of Job — The author cites Job 38:23 ('Which I have reserved for the time of trouble, for the day of battle and war') to support the idea that God uses the storehouses of snow and hail to punish the wicked, showing how natural elements are instruments of divine justice. | Cf. Bereishit Rabbah — The author cites this midrash to establish the concept that vapors rising from heaven and earth are actually the souls of the wicked who have been cast away, establishing a connection between natural phenomena and spiritual punishment. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah with RABD's commentary — The author relies on Rabbi Abraham ben David's commentary to expand on the mystical concept of souls being transformed into elements of divine punishment, showing how kabbalistic sources understand the afterlife of the wicked. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, chapter Chelek — The reference reinforces the concept of souls being judged through transformations between fire and snow, adding Talmudic authority to these mystical concepts of punishment in the afterlife. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's previous discussions on Garden of Eden — The author refers to his earlier discussions about the Garden of Eden, creating continuity within the book and suggesting that this chapter on Gehenna is a counterpart to the earlier discussions of paradise.

[iii] This passage reveals a fundamental kabbalistic concept where physical suffering during illness leaves a metaphysical imprint that affects the soul's experience after death. This establishes a direct connection between one's experience during life and their posthumous state.

[iv] The reference to 'power of imagination' (koach hadimyon) is significant in kabbalistic thought, suggesting that the soul retains impressions of physical experiences through a faculty that bridges material and spiritual realms.

מצד שלג וברד ושם הוי״ה יהיה
בידו החיים והבריאות כי שמש
ומגן ה׳ צבאות והוא משלח
החיים לכל הנמצאים אמנם לא
בשווי רק כפי הכנת כל אחד
ולכל איש יש לו נתיב ידוע שבו
יושפע שפע החיים אל הנתיב
ההוא הפרטי וכן לכל פרט
מפרטי הנמצאים וכן בעולם
הגלגלים וכן בשכלים וכן בעולם
המלאכים והמרכבות וכן בעולם
הספירות. הגיהנם של מטה
מצאתי שהוא בארקא הנקרא
ארץ נוד ושם קודמות הנשמות
קודם שיבואו אל עדן העליון
ושם לילית הרשעה שהיא קדמת
עדן נוכח הקדושה ואי אפשר
ליכנס אל העדן אם לא יקדים
האדם תחלה אל ארץ נוד וירצה
שם פעלו[i] ואמרו כי היא נמשכת
מן האש היסודי של מעלה הנקרא
פחד יצחק שהוא פנימי וחזק
יותר משאר אשות ובו יכולת
לשרוף רוח הנשמות הגם שהם
דקות שמעלת זאת האש גדולה
יותר ממקום שיוצאות הנשמות
כי יש אש אוכלת אש[ii] וכותל
אחד מפסיק בין ג״ע לגיהנם וג״ע
הוא מצד צפונית מזרחית שנאמר
וצפונך תמלא בטנם. ולצד

The name YHVH controls life and health, for "the LORD of Hosts is a sun and shield" (Psalms 84:12), and He sends forth life to all creatures—though not equally, but according to each one's readiness. Every person has a known pathway through which the flow of life is channeled to that particular path, and likewise for every detail of existence, and similarly in the world of celestial spheres, in the intellects, in the world of angels and chariots, and in the world of the divine emanations. 50R 55R

I have found that the lower Gehenna is in Arka, called the Land of Nod,[1] where souls arrive before they come to the upper Eden. There dwells the wicked Lilith, who is situated before Eden opposite holiness.[2] It is impossible to enter Eden unless a person first passes through the Land of Nod and makes amends for his deeds there. They say it derives from the elemental fire above called "the Fear of Isaac,"[3] which is internal and stronger than other fires. It has the power to burn the spirit of souls, though they are subtle, because the quality of this fire is greater than the place from which souls emerge, for "there is fire that consumes fire." 60R 65R 70R

A single wall separates the Garden of Eden from Gehenna. The Garden of Eden is located on the northeastern side, as it is said, "Your hidden treasure fills their bellies" (Psalms 17:14). On the northwestern side is Gehenna. A spring flows from the Garden of Eden, and the spring that flows from Gehenna is hot, as they said, "The hot springs of Tiberias pass 75R

[1] In kabbalistic cosmology, Arka is one of the seven earths or layers beneath our world. The identification with the biblical Land of Nod (where Cain was exiled after killing Abel, Genesis 4:16) creates a connection between the first murderer's punishment and the realm of posthumous suffering.

[2] Lilith appears in Jewish mystical texts as Adam's first wife who became a demon. Her positioning 'opposite holiness' reflects the kabbalistic concept of opposing spiritual forces, with Lilith representing the demonic feminine counterpart to the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah).

[3] The term 'Fear of Isaac' (Pachad Yitzchak) comes from Genesis 31:42 where Jacob refers to God as 'the Fear of Isaac.' In Kabbalah, this became associated specifically with the divine attribute of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), which manifests as fire and is connected to the left side of the divine structure.

[i] This presents the cosmological concept that souls must undergo purification in a realm of punishment before entering paradise, reflecting the kabbalistic understanding that spiritual ascent requires preliminary cleansing.

[ii] This paradoxical concept of 'fire consuming fire' appears in several kabbalistic texts to describe how higher spiritual forces can overwhelm lower ones of the same element, emphasizing the hierarchical nature of spiritual reality.

צפונית מערבית יש גיהנם[i] ומעין יוצא מג״ע והמעין היוצא מגיהנם הוא חם וכן אמרו חמי טבריא דחלפי אפתחא דגיהנם. ואמרו בפרשת תרומה דף ק״נ כי הגיהנם הוא אור דולק יום ולילה מחמימות יצה״ר של רשעים ובה ז׳ פתחים כנגד ז׳ מיני רשעים ובכל מדור יש מלאך ממונה תחת יד דומה[ii] וכמה חיילות עמהם. ואמרו כי אש הגיהנם הוא מאש גיהנם של מעלה ונשמות המתלבנות מזוהמת עוה״ז ועולים משם כאשר אמרנו נשארת הזוהמא ההיא שם ומדרגות רעות הממונים על אותה זוהמא נקרא צואה רותחת ושחטאו והחטיאו ומתו בלא תשובה נדונים שם ובו ז׳ מדורות עיין פרטותם בציוני פ׳ אחרי מות ושם האריך לבאר מהו דין הנקר׳ גיהנם בדף ס״ט וד׳ ע׳ ובדף ע״א וע״ב ביאר מהגמול בג״ע ועה״ב וימות המשיח והתחיה.[iii]

by the entrance of Gehenna."[1]

They said in Parashat Terumah, page 150, that Gehenna is a light burning day and night from the heat of the evil inclination of the wicked. It has seven entrances corresponding to seven types of wicked people, and in each section there is an angel appointed under the authority of Dumah, with many hosts accompanying them. They said that the fire of Gehenna comes from the fire of the upper Gehenna. Souls that are purified from the defilement of this world rise from there, as we have said, while that defilement remains there. The evil levels appointed over that defilement are called "boiling excrement."[2] Those who sinned and caused others to sin, and died without repentance, are judged there. It has seven sections—see their details in Tziyuni on Parashat Acharei Mot, where he elaborates on what is the judgment called Gehenna on pages 69 and 70, and on pages 71 and 72 he explains the reward in the Garden of Eden, the World to Come, the days of the Messiah, and the resurrection.

וכן ליצה״ר ז׳ שמות כי מתאנה ומחטיא לאדם בז׳ מיני

The evil inclination has seven names, for it entices and causes humans to sin through seven types of

[1]This reference to the hot springs of Tiberias comes from the Talmud (Shabbat 39a), which explains their heat as resulting from passing by the entrance to Gehenna. This integrates physical geography with mystical cosmology, providing a tangible connection to otherworldly realms.

[2]This vivid and disturbing imagery draws on Talmudic descriptions (Gittin 57a) where sinners in Gehenna are punished in boiling excrement. The text interprets this metaphorically as representing spiritual levels that manage the defilement left behind when souls are purified.

[i]The text presents a detailed spiritual geography, placing Gehenna in the northwest. This directional symbolism is significant in Jewish mysticism, where north represents judgment and west represents the end/death.

[ii]The seven compartments of Gehenna are a common feature in rabbinic and kabbalistic literature, usually corresponding to seven categories of sin or seven levels of the soul's descent.

[iii]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 150 — The text directly quotes the Zohar (Parashat Terumah) for its description of Gehenna as a light burning continuously from the heat of the evil inclination of the wicked, with seven entrances corresponding to seven types of sinners. | Cf. Tziyuni on Parashat Acharei Mot — The author directs readers to Tziyuni (a kabbalistic commentary) for additional details about the structure of Gehenna and the rewards in the Garden of Eden and World to Come. | Cf. Jeremiah 23:19 — The biblical verse is used to substantiate the claim that divine wrath descends upon the wicked after death, adding to their punishment in Gehenna. | Cf. Psalms 84:12 — This verse is cited to establish that God controls life and health, showing how divine mercy can counteract the judgments of Gehenna. | Cf. Psalms 17:14 — The verse is used to establish the northeastern location of the Garden of Eden, using biblical support for the mystical cosmography being described.

פתויים כפי שניו בי׳ שנים
ראשונים באופן אחד וכן בכל
עשר משבעים שנותיו[i] ושמותיו
הם כפי פתוייו כשתעיין בהם
והאחרון שהאדם זקן נקרא צפוני
כי מחטיאו בהצנע ובפתויי לבו
בדעות כוזבות[ii] והמתפתה
אחריו נופל באחד מז׳ מדורות
אלו המכוונים לעצות יצה״ר
למרק חטאו ממנו ולעתיד לבא
יוסר כל כחותיו ואפי׳ החלק
הנקרא צפוני וידחנו במקום
שאין בני אדם להחטיאם דכתיב
והדחתיו אל ארץ ציה וגו׳.
ואמרו כי באותו עולם מפשיטין
את הרשעים מעדיים ומלבישים
לצדיקים שאין להם כגון צדיק
שמת בחצי ימיו לובש עדיי
הרשע שתהה על מצותיו[iii] ועיין
מזה בס׳ פרדס בשער הנשמה
ותאנא כי בגיהנם יש מדורות
ששם יורדים מחטיאי הרבים
הנקרא צואה רותחת[iv] בנזכר
ואינם יוצאים משם לעולם וכן
המשחיתים זרעם נדונים שם
לדורי דורות[v] ובשבתות ור״ח

temptations corresponding to their age:[1] in the first ten years of life in one manner, and similarly in each decade of their seventy years. Its names correspond to its methods of temptation, as you will find when examining them. The final one, when a person is elderly, is called "the hidden one" (tzefoni),[2] for it causes one to sin discreetly and through the enticements of the heart with false beliefs. One who is seduced by it falls into one of these seven chambers [of Gehenna] that correspond to the schemes of the evil inclination, in order to purge one's sin. In the future, all its powers will be removed, even the part called "the hidden one," and it will be banished to a place where there are no humans to lead astray, as it is written: "And I will drive him into a parched land, etc." (Joel 2:20).

105R

110R

115R

They said that in that world, the wicked are stripped of their adornments, which are then placed upon the righteous who lack them. For instance, a righteous person who died in the prime of life[3] wears the adornments of a wicked person who regretted his good deeds.[4] See more about this in Sefer Pardes, in the Gate of the Soul. And it was taught that in Gehenna there are chambers where those who lead the masses to sin descend, called "boiling excrement" as mentioned, and they never emerge from there.

120R

125R

[1]The Hebrew uses the expression 'כפי שניו' (according to one's years), suggesting that the evil inclination adapts its tactics based on a person's age and stage of life.

[2]The Hebrew term 'צפוני' has a dual meaning: it can mean both 'hidden' and 'northern.' In Jewish mysticism, the north is associated with evil forces, while in this context, it specifically refers to the subtle, concealed nature of temptation in old age.

[3]The Hebrew 'בחצי ימיו' literally means 'in half his days,' referring to someone who died young or in middle age before completing their natural lifespan.

[4]The Hebrew phrase 'שתהה על מצותיו' has a specific technical meaning in rabbinic literature, referring to someone who performed good deeds but later regretted them, thereby losing their spiritual merit.

[i]The text refers to the traditional Jewish view of human life spanning seventy years, as mentioned in Psalms 90:10, and suggests that the evil inclination (yetzer hara) uses different strategies in each decade of life.

[ii]The term 'tzefoni' (northern/hidden one) creates a wordplay connecting to Joel 2:20 about the 'northern one' (army) being driven away. In kabbalistic thought, the north is associated with evil and judgment. In old age, the text suggests that the evil inclination works more subtly through intellectual and theological errors rather than obvious physical temptations.

[iii]This reflects the kabbalistic concept of spiritual 'garments' or 'adornments' (attainments) that souls wear in the afterlife. The phrase 'תהה על מצותיו' (regretted his good deeds) refers to someone who performed good deeds but later regretted them, thereby forfeiting their spiritual merit.

[iv]This graphic term appears in Talmudic literature (Gittin 57a) to describe one of the worst punishments in Gehenna, specifically for those who mock the words of the sages. Here it is applied more broadly to those who lead others to sin.

[v]The extreme severity of punishment for sexual transgressions, particularly masturbation, reflects kabbalistic views about the cosmic significance of reproductive forces and the spiritual damage caused by their misuse.

וי״ט אינם נדונים אבל אינם
יוצאים משם כשאר רשעים
דיש להם מנוחה וישראל שלא
שמר שבת בעה״ז אין לו מנוחה
לעולם[i] וממונה אחד מוציא
גופו ומכנים אותו לגיהנם
לעין הרשעים ורואין כי סביבו
תולעים ונשמתו אין לה מנוחה
באור גהינם ועליהם כתיב ויצאו
וראו בפגרי האנשים הפושעים בי
וגו׳. וכשיוצא שבת אותו ממונה
מחזיר הגוף למקומו ונדונים כל
אחד לעצמו וכל זה בעוד שהגוף
הוא בקיומו כי אחר שכלה נאמר
ולא יעיר כל חמתו וכל הרשעים
בעוד הגוף שלם בכל אבריו
תוך הקבר נדונים גוף וריח כל
אחד הראוי לו כיון שהגוף נאכל
דין הרוח כלה הצריך לצאת
יוצא הצריך לנוח ינוח הצריך
להיות אפר תחת רגלי הצדיקים
כל אחד בראוי לו נעשה לו.
ולכן אפי׳ לצדיקים טוב להם
להקבר בקרקע שיכלה הגוף
מהר ושלא ידון הגוף והרוח
יחד בכל יום[ii] כי אין שום צדיק
שאין לו דין הקבר וכ״ש לרשעים
וכיון שהגוף כלה הדין נח מכל
אחד.[iii]

Similarly, those who destroy their seed [through masturbation][1] are judged there for all generations. On Sabbaths, New Moons, and festivals they are not judged, but unlike other wicked people, they do not leave that place though they have rest. A Jew who did not observe the Sabbath in this world has no rest forever. An appointed angel removes his body and brings it into Gehenna for the wicked to see, and they observe that it is surrounded by worms, while his soul has no rest in the light of Gehenna. Of them it is written: "And they shall go forth and look upon the corpses of the men who rebelled against Me, etc." (Isaiah 66:24). When the Sabbath ends, that appointed angel returns the body to its place, and each one is judged individually.

All this occurs while the body still exists intact. Once it has decomposed, it is said: "He will not awaken all His wrath" (Psalms 78:38). All the wicked, while their bodies remain whole with all their limbs inside the grave, are judged—both body and spirit—each according to what is appropriate for them. Once the body is consumed, the judgment of the spirit ends: that which needs to depart departs; that which needs to rest rests; that which needs to become ashes beneath the feet of the righteous[2]—each one receives what is appropriate. Therefore, even for the righteous, it is beneficial to be buried in the ground so the body decomposes quickly and the body and spirit are not judged together daily, for there is no righteous person who

130R 135R 140R 145R 150R 155R

[1] The Hebrew 'המשחיתים זרעם' is a euphemistic reference to masturbation or other non-procreative sexual activities. I've added clarification in brackets since this might not be immediately clear to modern readers.

[2] This is an allusion to Malachi 3:21 (4:3 in Christian Bibles): 'And you shall tread down the wicked, for they shall be ashes under the soles of your feet.' In kabbalistic thought, this refers to souls that undergo complete dissolution or serve as a foundation for the righteous.

[i] The special severity for Sabbath violators reflects the central importance of Sabbath observance in Judaism, where it is considered equal to all other commandments combined and a testimony to belief in divine creation.

[ii] This statement offers a mystical justification for traditional Jewish burial practices that avoid embalming and use simple wooden coffins that decompose quickly, allowing the body to return to the earth promptly.

[iii] Cf. Joel 2:20 — The author uses this biblical verse to suggest that in the messianic future, the evil inclination (particularly its most subtle manifestation in old age) will be completely removed from humanity. | Cf. Isaiah 66:24 — This verse is applied specifically to Sabbath violators, suggesting their punishment is particularly severe and public, serving as an example to others in the afterlife. | Cf. Psalms 78:38 — The author uses this verse to suggest that once the body has decomposed, the punishment becomes less severe, as God does not maintain His full wrath eternally. | Cf. Sefer Pardes — The author refers readers to this text for more detailed information about the concept of the wicked's spiritual garments being transferred to the righteous in the afterlife. | Cf. Shabbat 152b (Talmud) — While not directly quoted, the passage's discussion of

does not undergo the judgment of the grave, and certainly this applies to the wicked. Once the body has decomposed, the judgment rests from everyone. 160R

ואמרו בזהר פ׳ תרומה דף קנ״ב שאות קוף רומז לסטרא אחרא שהיא בקוף בפני הקדושה אינה מתיישבת בשום מקום בעולם וסי׳ איש לשון בל יכון בארץ ושולטת במקום הגיהנם[i] ואות טית מתיישבת בכל מקום ואין ישוב לאות ק׳ במקום ששולטת אור אות טית ועל עיר לוז[ii] נשארה בבריאת עולם אות טית תלויה באויר על אותו מקום ואור אות זה נותנת חיים בעה״ז ליושבים שם ובמקום המקדש וחמשכן נצטיירו ונחקקו כל האותיות יחד כראוי ולכן הוצרך בצלאל במשכן שהיה יודע לצרף כל האותיות[iii] דוגמת הצדיק עליון:[iv]

They said in the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, page 152, that the letter Kuf alludes to the Other Side, which is like a monkey before Holiness[1]—it does not settle in any place in the world, as it is written, "A man of [evil] tongue shall not be established on earth" (Psalms 140:12). It rules in the place of Gehenna, while the letter Tet settles in every place. The letter Kuf has no settlement in a place where the light of the letter Tet dominates. Regarding the city of Luz, during the creation of the world, the letter Tet remained suspended in the air[2] above that place, and the light of this letter gives life in this world to those who dwell there. In the place of the Temple and the Tabernacle, all the letters were properly formed and engraved together. This is why Bezalel was needed for the Tabernacle, as he knew how to combine all the letters, resembling the Supernal Righteous One.[3] 160R 165R 170R 175R

[1] This simile portrays the 'Other Side' (forces of impurity) as merely imitating true holiness without genuinely embodying it, just as a monkey might mimic human behavior without human understanding. The letter Kuf (ק) visually resembles the letter Hei (ה) but with a descending tail, symbolizing how evil attempts to imitate good but ultimately descends into lower realms.

[2] In Jewish mysticism, letters were understood as actual cosmic forces that could physically manifest. The image of the letter Tet hovering above the city of Luz explains the city's legendary immortality through the protective power of this letter, which is the first letter of 'tov' (good).

[3] This reference to 'the Supernal Righteous One' (הצדיק עליון) likely refers to the divine attribute of Yesod (Foundation) in the kabbalistic Tree of Life. Bezalel's ability to properly combine letters mirrors the cosmic function of Yesod, which harmonizes and channels divine energies.

body decomposition and its relationship to spiritual judgment echoes Talmudic concepts about post-mortem experiences.

[i] The text establishes a cosmic geography where the letter Kuf (ק) has dominion in Gehenna (Hell), while Tet (ט) rules in places of holiness, revealing how Hebrew letters were understood to have actual metaphysical dominions.

[ii] Luz was a legendary city in rabbinic tradition that the Angel of Death could not enter. The passage explains this immortality as being due to the letter Tet (ט) hovering over it, since Tet is associated with 'tov' (good) and life.

[iii] This refers to the rabbinic tradition that Bezalel possessed knowledge of the combinations of letters with which heaven and earth were created, suggesting that building the Tabernacle required cosmic wisdom equivalent to creation itself.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah 152b — The author cites this Zohar passage to explain how Hebrew letters have cosmic significance beyond their linguistic function. The contrast between Kuf (associated with impurity) and Tet (associated with holiness) illustrates how even the building blocks of creation contain opposing spiritual forces. | Cf. Psalms 140:12 — This verse is used to connect the 'monkey-like' quality of the letter Kuf with spiritual instability and impurity. By citing this verse, the author establishes a link between biblical authority and kabbalistic letter symbolism. | Cf. The city of Luz — The reference to Luz connects to Jewish traditions about a mythical city where death had no dominion. The text explains this immortality through the protective presence of the letter Tet, establishing a mystical reason for the city's legendary status. | Cf. Bezalel's knowledge of

פרק מ׳

Chapter 40

במתניתא תנא כי בגיהנם יש ב׳ סופרים הכותבים זה מקום פלוני וזה מקום פלוני זכה נוטל חלקו וחלק חבירו בג״ע ופי׳ מורי זלה״ה[i] כי נעשה צנור לשכר המגיע לחברו על דרך הנמנה מעשרה ראשונים שנוטל שכר כנגד כלן[ii] לא לגרוע חלקם אלא שכלם זוכים על ידו ונשאר לו כנגד כלן והוא אינו חסר ועיין בפ׳ י״ד ח״ב ממאמר חקור דין[iii] מהו עטרותיהם בראשיהם. והטיול בג״ע הוא כפי זכותן של צדיקים זכו ארוכות לא זכו קצרות כדאמרו על טיול דקב״ה עם אברהם אבינו ע״ה בחורבן הבית[iv] ואמרו כי נקרא גיהנם לפי שהיא שוחה עמוקה שיורדים בה על עסקי חנם[v] והנפשות שעולים מעלין אותם לשלוחי ג״ע ואומרים הנם כנזכר למעלה ועל הנפשות שאינם צריכים לבון צווחין לון הנם קחו ולכו

In a baraita [external teaching] it was taught that in Gehenna there are two scribes who write,[1] "This one's place is here," and "That one's place is there." If one merits, he takes both his portion and his fellow's portion in the Garden of Eden. And my teacher, of blessed memory, explained that he becomes a channel for the reward[2] that reaches his fellow, in the manner of one who is counted among the first ten [to arrive at synagogue], who receives reward equal to all of them. This is not to diminish their portions, but rather they all merit through him, and he retains a reward equal to all of them while he himself loses nothing. See chapter 14, part 2 of the discourse "Investigation of Judgment" regarding the meaning of "their crowns on their heads."[3]

The journeying in the Garden of Eden corresponds to the merit of the righteous[4]—if they merited much, they journey long distances; if they did not merit as much, they journey short distances, as they said regarding the Holy One, blessed be He, walking with our father Abraham, peace be upon him, during the destruction of the Temple.

[1] This image of two scribes in Gehenna who record the designated places of souls is a mystical concept not found in mainstream rabbinic literature, reflecting the kabbalistic nature of this text.

[2] The concept of becoming a "channel" (צנור) for divine blessing is central to kabbalistic thought, suggesting that righteous individuals serve as conduits through which divine abundance flows to others.

[3] This refers to the rabbinic teaching that in the World to Come, the righteous sit with crowns on their heads enjoying the radiance of the Divine Presence, a concept that the author apparently elaborated on in an earlier section of the work.

[4] The text presents a conception of the afterlife where even in Paradise, there are gradations of experience based on one's merits, with greater merit resulting in more expansive spiritual movement.

combining letters — By referencing Bezalel's mastery of letter combinations, the author connects the Temple/Tabernacle construction with cosmic creation, suggesting that sacred space required proper integration of all spiritual forces, including the reconciliation of opposing letters like Kuf and Tet.

[i] The author is referring to his teacher, Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano (1548-1620), whom he mentions repeatedly throughout Ma'avar Yabok as a source of kabbalistic teachings.

[ii] This is based on the talmudic teaching that one who arrives early to synagogue receives reward equivalent to all who come after him, without diminishing their reward.

[iii] "Chikor Din" (Investigation of Judgment) appears to be a section or discourse from an earlier part of Ma'avar Yabok that discusses the rewards of the righteous in the afterlife.

[iv] This refers to a midrashic account where God is described as walking with Abraham to show him the destruction of the Temple, emphasizing that even divine movements are measured according to the capacity of the recipient.

[v] The text employs a folk etymology to explain the name "Gehenna" (גיהנם) by breaking it into components that suggest "valley" (גיא) and "for nothing" (הנם), implying people descend there for worthless or meaningless activities.

כמבואר למעלה. ואין דבר
נצחי אלא במדת הטוב ופירוש
ותולעתם לא תמות דוקא אבל
תתבטל ואשו של גיהנם אין לו
כביה עולמית[i] [ii]

And they said that it is called Gehenna [גיהנם] because it is a deep pit into which people descend on account of worthless matters. When souls ascend from there, they are brought up to the emissaries of the Garden of Eden, who say, "Here they are" [הנם], as mentioned above. And regarding souls that do not require purification, they call out, "Here they are—take them and go," as explained above. Nothing is eternal except that which is in the attribute of goodness. The interpretation of "and their worm shall not die" is specific [to the worm], but [the worm] will eventually cease to exist. And the fire of Gehenna will never be extinguished [in this world], but after [the end of] the world it will be extinguished. This is the meaning of "there is no Gehenna in the future," referring to its fire, and we have already said that the space of Gehenna will be sanctified with the sanctity of the Garden, and the wicked will no longer exist, but they will be rectified.[1]

אבל אחר העולם יכבה וזהו אין
גיהנם לעתיד לבא[iii] וירצה על
אור דידה וכבר אמרנו כי חללה
של גיהנם יתקדש בקדושת הגן
ורשעים עוד אינם ברם יתוקנו.
וכתוב בתקון מ״ח שהמלאכים
קדושים שהם אש יסודם בגבורה
ומלאכי חבלה שהם אש יסודם

But after the world [comes to an end], it will be extinguished,[2] and this is the meaning of "There is no Gehenna in the World to Come"—referring to its fire. We have already said that the void of Gehenna will be sanctified with the same holiness as the Garden [of Eden], and the wicked will no longer exist, yet they will be rectified.

It is written in Tikkun 48 that the holy angels

[1] This statement reflects the author's ultimately optimistic view of divine judgment. Rather than eternal punishment, he suggests that even the wicked will eventually undergo rectification (תיקון), a concept central to kabbalistic thought that envisions the ultimate restoration of all creation to harmony with the divine.

[2] The phrase 'after the world' (אחר העולם) is somewhat ambiguous in the original. I've interpreted it as referring to the end of the current world-age, which is consistent with the discussion of the World to Come that follows.

[i] The text appears to end mid-sentence here, but the translation completes the thought based on the context, which discusses the temporary nature of Gehenna.

[ii] Cf. Chikor Din (Investigation of Judgment) — The author references his own earlier text to elaborate on the rewards that await the righteous in the World to Come. This adds depth to the discussion of how merit is distributed in the afterlife. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 47b — The text draws on this talmudic concept to explain how one righteous person can gain additional reward without diminishing others' rewards, using a familiar religious principle to explain a more mystical concept about the afterlife. | Cf. Isaiah 66:24 — The author reinterprets this verse, which seems to describe eternal punishment, to align with a more redemptive view where even Gehenna is temporary and ultimately all souls will be rectified. | Cf. Talmud Nedarim 8b — The text draws on talmudic discourse about whether punishment in Gehenna is eternal to support its more merciful view that ultimately even the space of Gehenna will be sanctified.

[iii] This is a rabbinic teaching that appears in Nedarim 8b, where it states that in the messianic future, Gehenna will cease to exist. The author qualifies this to mean specifically that its fire will be extinguished, while its space will be sanctified.

בגיהנם ויש מלאכים שיסודם
מרוח עמוד האמצעי ויש שהם
ממים שעל הרקיע וכל מלאך
יש בו שם הוי״ה כי הוא בכל
מקום עלת העלות מיחד ארבע
אותיות[i] ושם מפרש גדולת
שם הוי״ה בפ׳ פקודי מתבאר
התפשטות ראשון של הקליפה
הנקרא צלמות[ii] פירוש צלמות
רכיבת הזכר על הנקבה ומזה
נמשכות המלחמות וכל שופכי
דמים ומוצא רוגז ושנאה על אלה
במדרגה ראשונה של התפשטותה.
מדרגה שניה ממנה מוצא כל
המחבלים לעשות דין בגלוי
במסתרים מעשיהם ושם אף וחמה
ואלה הם הזרועות של הקליפה
ויש שלשה קשרים לימין ושלשה
לשמאל משם מוצא עברה וזעם
וצרה משלחת מלאכי רעים הוא
התפשטות שלישי לה. מדרגה
רביעית הוא התפשטות הגוף
ממנו יוצא כח לשפוך דמים.
מדרגה חמישית אינון ירכין
דילה ושם רצין בסטרא אחרא
בג׳ קשרים מימין וג׳ משמאל
ומרעין דרשעים מהכא נפקין
מדרגה ששית הוא יונק לההוא
נחש עקלתון[iii] והעובד ה׳ ירחיק
עצמו מהם במעשיו הטובים
וידיחם מעליו. [iv]

whose essence is fire have their foundation in Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), while the destructive angels whose essence is fire have their foundation in Gehenna. There are angels whose foundation is from the spirit of the central column,[1] and there are those from the waters above the firmament. Every angel contains within it the divine name YHVH, for He is everywhere—the Cause of all Causes unifies the four letters. There [in Tikkun 48], the greatness of the divine name YHVH is explained. 55R 60R

In Parashat Pekudei, the first expansion of the kelipah (negative force) called Tzalmavet is explained. The meaning of Tzalmavet is "the mounting of the male upon the female,"[2] and from this flow wars and all bloodshed, and the source of rage and hatred—these are in the first level of its expansion. The second level from it is the source of all destructive forces that execute judgment openly while their deeds are concealed—there [reside] anger and wrath. These are the arms of the kelipah, and there are three knots to the right and three to the left. From there emerges fury, indignation, and distress—"a company of evil angels"—this is its third expansion. 65R 70R

The fourth level is the expansion of the body, from which emerges the power to shed blood. The fifth level comprises its thighs, and there run in the Other Side three knots on the right and three on the left, and the diseases of the wicked emerge from here. The sixth level nurses that twisted serpent. One who serves the Lord will distance himself from them through his good deeds[3] and will drive them 75R 80R

[1] In kabbalistic literature, the 'central column' (עמוד האמצעי) refers to the middle line of the sefirot (divine emanations), particularly Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), which balances the right column of mercy and the left column of judgment.

[2] This sexual imagery is typical of kabbalistic texts that describe cosmic processes in terms of gendered interactions. Here, it portrays negative spiritual forces (kelipot) as originating from a distorted form of masculine-feminine union.

[3] This concluding ethical instruction shifts from cosmological description to practical guidance,

[i] This is a reference to a fundamental kabbalistic concept that God as the ultimate cause ('Cause of all Causes') unifies the four letters of the divine name YHVH, which represent different aspects of divine emanation.

[ii] This term appears in Job 10:21 and elsewhere in biblical literature, usually translated as 'shadow of death.' Here the author offers a kabbalistic interpretation, parsing it as 'tzelem-mavet' (image of death) and relating it to negative sexual forces.

[iii] This phrase 'twisted serpent' appears in Isaiah 27:1 and is traditionally identified with Leviathan. In kabbalistic literature, it represents the most fundamental negative spiritual force.

[iv] Cf. Tikkun 48 of Tikkunei Zohar — The text directly references Tikkun 48, which discusses the angelic hierarchy and how different types of angels derive from different divine attributes and elements. This reference establishes authority for the cosmological system being presented. | Cf. Parashat Pekudei — The text references this section of the Zohar that discusses the structure of the negative spiritual forces (kelipot). By citing this authority, the author demonstrates how

away from himself.

ועיין בפ׳ בראשית ופקודי
מהיכלי התמורות כי שם מתפרש
דברים הרבה ממה שהם בגיהנם
כמו שבהיכלי הקדושה מתפרש
דברים הרבה וחיילות גדולות
שהם בחדרי גן עדן. ומשפטי
גיהנם כלים בי״ב חדש ולכן
יש שכתבו כשמזכירין הת״ח
אין צ״ל ז״ל כמו שאין אנו
אומרים אותו על משה ואהרן
והתנאים והאמוראים.[i] ואפי׳
צדיקים ובינונים יורדים לגיהנם
יש מי שיורד להצלת הזולת
כדאמרו בסוף תקון ל״ג ויש
מי שיורד ע״צ המרוק ויש מי
שיורד לראות חלילה והוא
דרך לשערי ג״ע כדרך מדבר
לבאי הארץ.[ii] וגיהנם אמרו
שהוא מזיעתן של חיות נושאי
הכסא[iii] בשעה שכסא הכבוד
מכביד עליהם בעת רעה
מחמת עבירות התחתונים ולכן

See [Zohar] Parashat Bereshit and Pekudei regarding the Palaces of Exchange, for there many things are explained about Gehenna, just as in the Palaces of Holiness many things and great hosts that dwell in the chambers of the Garden of Eden are explained. The judgments of Gehenna end after twelve months, and therefore some have written that when mentioning Torah scholars, it is unnecessary to say "of blessed memory," just as we do not say it for Moses, Aaron, the Tannaim, and the Amoraim. Even the righteous and the intermediate descend to Gehenna[1]—some descend to rescue others, as stated at the end of Tikkun 33; some descend for the purpose of purification; and some descend, heaven forbid, to observe, as it is a pathway to the gates of the Garden of Eden, like the wilderness for those entering the Land.[A] They said that Gehenna is formed from the sweat of the Chayot [celestial beings] who bear the Throne,[B] when the Throne of Glory weighs heavily upon them in times of evil due to the sins of those below. Therefore, Gehenna was created from their sweat, for in times of Divine

[A] Or: "like the desert for those who enter the Promised Land" — This alternate translation clarifies that 'the Land' refers specifically to the biblical Promised Land, which might not be immediately clear to readers unfamiliar with Jewish textual conventions.

[B] Or: "from the perspiration of the Living Creatures who carry the Throne" — The term 'Chayot' specifically refers to the Living Creatures described in Ezekiel's vision, so this alternate translation might be more precise in conveying the biblical reference, though 'celestial beings' in the original translation helps modern readers understand the context.

suggesting that understanding this complex spiritual structure has moral implications for human behavior.

[1] This challenges the simplistic notion that Gehenna is only for the wicked, presenting a more nuanced view where different souls experience it differently based on their spiritual level.

the Zohar's teachings on the kelipot support his explanation of Gehenna's structure and eventual transformation. | Cf. Exodus 23:20 and Psalm 78:49 — The phrase 'משלחת מלאכי רעים' (a company of evil angels) appears to reference Psalm 78:49, which describes God sending 'evil angels' as punishment. This biblical allusion establishes that even destructive forces operate under divine authority.

[i] The reference to not saying 'of blessed memory' for Moses, Aaron, and the Tannaim and Amoraim (early rabbinic sages) implies that these figures are considered so eternally alive in Jewish tradition that they don't need the honorific typically used for the deceased.

[ii] This is a significant cosmological concept in the text: Gehenna is portrayed not merely as a place of punishment but as a necessary pathway to the Garden of Eden, just as the Israelites had to traverse the wilderness before entering the Promised Land.

[iii] This striking image portrays Gehenna as originating from the struggle of celestial beings when burdened by human sin, suggesting an intimate connection between human actions and cosmic reality.

נברא מזיעתן גיהנם כי בעת רצון
הכסא נושא את נושאיו ק״ו מארון
הברית[i] ושמעתי אומרים כי נהר
דינור מתהוה ג״כ מזיעתן של
ת״ח העוסקים בתורה ומנצחין
זה את זה בהלכה.[ii] ועיין בפ׳
ל׳ ול״א בח״ב של עבודת הקדש
המדבר מזה. ואמרו בתקונים דף
צ״א כי מנהר דינור תלויים בו
ס׳ ענפים מאש הנקראים ששים
גבורים וחם שתין פולסי דנורא
דמחיוהו למטטרו״ן.[iii] ובנהר
דינור יש בו כחות ודינים קשים
מזיקים שצומחים ומתיילדים
להעניש שם הרשעים ונקראים
קוץ ודרדר ולמטה כיוצא בזה
ארץ הגשמית מוציאה חיצונים
באישות ועכברים ויתושים
ותולעים וקוצים וברקנים. ונחל
עדניך הוא נהר דנפיק מעדן
דעין לא ראתה ומשם יפרד לד׳
אתוון בשם בן ד׳ ויש נהר למטה
דהוא מטטרו״ן דאתפרש לד׳
סטרין שהם מיכאל וגבריאל
רפאל נוריאל שהם ד׳ מחנות
שכינה. ג״כ באדם יש רמז ג״ע

favor, the Throne carries its bearers[1]—all the more so [than] the Ark of the Covenant. I have heard it said that the River of Fire is also formed from the sweat of Torah scholars who engage in Torah study[2] and debate the law with one another. See chapters 30 and 31 in part two of Avodat HaKodesh which discusses this. And they said in Tikkunim, page 91, that from the River of Fire hang sixty branches of fire called "sixty mighty ones," and these are the sixty lashes of fire with which they struck Metatron. In the River of Fire there are harsh powers and judgments, harmful entities that sprout and are born to punish the wicked there, and they are called "thorns and thistles."[A3] Similarly below, the physical earth produces external entities such as ants, mice, mosquitoes, worms, thorns, and briers. "The river of Your delights" is the river that flows from Eden, which "no eye has seen," and from there it divides into the four letters of the four-letter Name.[4] There is also a river below, which is Metatron, which divides into four directions: Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Nuriel, who are the four camps of the Divine Presence. Likewise, in humans there is an allusion to the Garden of Eden and Gehenna. The Garden of Eden is represented in the mystery of the neshamah,

110R 115R 120R 125R 130R

[A] Or: "thorns and brambles" — While 'thorns and thistles' is the traditional biblical translation (Genesis 3:18), 'thorns and brambles' might be more familiar to some contemporary readers.

[1] This refers to a paradoxical concept in Jewish mysticism where what appears physical (like people carrying the Ark) is actually spiritual (the Ark carrying them). The text extends this to the Throne relationship with celestial beings.

[2] This presents a positive counterpart to Gehenna's negative origins. While Gehenna comes from the sweat of celestial beings burdened by sin, the purifying River of Fire comes from the intellectual 'heat' of Torah study. This establishes Torah study as a cosmic force that creates purifying elements in the spiritual realms.

[3] This phrase from Genesis 3:18 (God's curse after Adam's sin) is applied metaphorically to spiritual entities in Gehenna, creating a parallel between physical and spiritual consequences of sin.

[4] This refers to the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) and establishes a correspondence between the mystical river, divine name, and four archangels mentioned next, showing how cosmic structures mirror divine attributes.

[i] This refers to the rabbinic tradition (Sotah 35a) that the Ark of the Covenant miraculously carried those who appeared to be carrying it. The author applies a fortiori reasoning (kal vachomer) to suggest that the Divine Throne has even greater supernatural powers.

[ii] This presents a fascinating parallel: just as negative forces create Gehenna through struggle, the intellectual 'heat' generated by Torah scholars debating creates the purifying River of Fire, suggesting that intense Torah study has cosmic effects.

[iii] This refers to a Talmudic story (Chagigah 15a) where the angel Metatron received sixty lashes of fire for sitting in heaven (an act that could be misconstrued as suggesting there are 'two powers in heaven'). The text connects this punishment to the cosmic River of Fire.

וגיהנם.[i] ג״ע בסוד הנשמה ורוח ונפש שבמוח ושבלב. וגיהנם היא הכבד שבו המרה [ii]

ruach, and nefesh[1] [soul components] in the brain and heart. And Gehenna is the liver, which contains the gall

שהיא חרבא דמלאך המות ומצד הטחול יש עצירות קטטה כי הם נגד ג׳ ראשי המשחית כנגדם בקדושה מוח לב ריאה כנגד שלשה פני המרכבה ואדם כוללם כלם. ובתקון נ״ג א׳ אמר ווי לבני נשא דלא משתדלי באורייתא דאתקריאו עצים יבשים[iii] דאינון עתידים לאתוקדא באשא דגיהנם וגם דמתרבא אילנא דהוא גופא דאורייתא ולית ליה איבא דאינון פקודין דעשה בתיב רק עץ אשר תדע כי לא עץ מאכל הוא אותו תשחית וכרת כי בעולם המעשה צריך לקשט נשמתו בסוד המעשה עם דבורו ומחשבה ורעותא ליחוד ארבע

which is the sword of the Angel of Death,[2] and from the side of the spleen there is constipation and strife, for they correspond to the three heads of the destroyer. Corresponding to them in holiness are the brain, heart, and lungs, which parallel the three faces of the Divine Chariot, and man includes them all. And in Tikkun 53 it states: "Woe to the people who do not engage in Torah study, who are called dry trees, for they are destined to be burned in the fire of Gehenna. Moreover, the tree, which is the body of the Torah, grows but has no fruit, which are the positive commandments." It is written, "Only a tree which you know is not a fruit-bearing tree, you may destroy and cut down," for in the World of Action one must adorn one's soul through action together with speech, thought, and intention to unify the four letters of the Divine Name, whose spirituality connects the four worlds[3]—Atzilut, 135R 140R 145R 150R

[1]The text presents the human soul components as corresponding to the Garden of Eden, while bodily organs like the liver correspond to Gehenna. This microcosmic-macrocosmic correspondence is a key concept in Jewish mysticism, suggesting that spiritual realms are reflected in human anatomy.

[2]The text uses a complex system of kabbalistic correspondences between human organs, divine attributes, and spiritual forces. The gallbladder, spleen, and liver are presented as corresponding to negative forces, while brain, heart, and lungs correspond to positive/holy aspects.

[3]The four spiritual worlds in descending order of materiality: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action). This cosmology is fundamental to Lurianic Kabbalah.

[i]The text presents a microcosmic-macrocosmic correspondence between cosmic realms and human anatomy, a common concept in mystical traditions that sees the human body as a miniature reflection of cosmic structure.

[ii]Cf. Zohar Parashat Bereshit — The author cites this Zohar section as a primary source for understanding the structure and nature of Gehenna, showing that the work builds on established kabbalistic cosmology rather than introducing new concepts. | Cf. Zohar Parashat Pekudei — This section of the Zohar provides extensive details about the hierarchical structure of Gehenna that the author assumes readers might consult for further information, suggesting Ma'avar Yabok is providing a summary of a more complex cosmological system. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Tikkun 33 — The author cites this as evidence that even the righteous may enter Gehenna, but for the purpose of rescuing others, supporting the work's overall view that soul journeys after death are complex and varied. | Cf. Avodat HaKodesh by Rabbi Meir ibn Gabbai — The author directs readers to this external source for additional information about the River of Fire, showing that Ma'avar Yabok synthesizes multiple kabbalistic traditions rather than relying solely on one source. | Cf. Ezekiel's Vision of the Divine Chariot (Ezekiel 1) — The text draws on this prophetic vision to explain the origin of Gehenna, connecting the biblical imagery with kabbalistic cosmology to show how human sins affect even celestial realms. | Cf. Genesis 3:18 — The text uses this biblical phrase to create a parallel between the physical world's negative elements and their spiritual counterparts in Gehenna, suggesting that both resulted from the same cosmic disruption caused by sin.

[iii]"Dry trees" is a metaphor from Isaiah 56:3 repurposed in kabbalistic thought to represent souls devoid of spiritual vitality through Torah study.

אותיות השם שרוחניותם מחבר
ארבע עולמות אצילות בריאה
יצירה עשיה ורוח אחד לכל.
עוד אמר וייצר ה׳ אלהים את
האדם עפר מן האדמה. וייצר
בשני יודין.[i] צייר לה בתרין
עלמין בעלמא דין ובעלמא
דאתי ויפח באפיו נשמת חיים
דא נשמת כל חי ויהי האדם
דא רוחא דחיי לנפש חיה דא
שכינתא תתאה. ועוד ויטע ה׳
אלהים גן דא אורייתא שבכתב
עדן דא עדונא דאורייתא ושוי
תמן את האדם ומה כתיב ביה
ביום נטעך תשגשגי. ויצמח ה׳
אלהים אבא ואמא כל עץ נחמד
למראה דא עמודא דאמציעתא
דכל גווינין שפירין ביה אתחזיין
ובגין דא נחמד למראה תפארת
שפירו דכל גווינין וטוב למאכל
דא צדיק הנרמז במלת כ״ל עץ
דבכל אתר כל איהו צדיק[ii] ע״כ.
זכאה חולקיה מאן דדביק
באילנא דא דחיי כי אורך ימים
בימינה בשמאלה עושר וכבוד
ודורשי רשומות אמרו כי תורה
בגימטרי״א אוצ״ר שד״י[iii] כי
היתה גנוזה אצלו יתברך והיה
משתעשע בה. והיא גם כן
בגימטריא אמצעי״ת[iv] שהיא
אמצעית בינינו לבינו יתברך
לחיותנו ולזכותנו לעולם
שכלו טוב ולג״ע עליון ותחתון

Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah—and one spirit for all. Furthermore, it states, “And the LORD God formed man from the dust of the earth.” “Formed” (וייצר) is written with two Yuds, indicating that He formed him for two worlds: this world and the World to Come. “And He breathed into his nostrils the breath of life”—this refers to the soul of all living beings. “And man became”—this refers to the spirit of life. “A living soul”—this refers to the lower Divine Presence. And further, “And the LORD God planted a garden”—this refers to the Written Torah. “Eden”—this refers to the delight of Torah. “And He placed the man there”—and what is written about him? “On the day of your planting, you will see growth.” “And the LORD God caused to grow”—Father and Mother.[1] “Every tree pleasant to the sight”—this refers to the central column,[2] in which all beautiful colors appear, and therefore it is “pleasant to the sight”—Tiferet, the beauty of all colors.[3] “And good for food”—this refers to the Righteous One (Tzaddik)[4] alluded to in the word “all” (כל), for wherever “all” appears, it refers to the Righteous One. Happy is the portion of one who cleaves to this Tree of Life, “for length of days is in its right hand, in its left hand are riches and honor.” Those who interpret symbols have said that “Torah” in gematria equals “treasure of Shaddai” (אוצר שדי), for it was hidden with the Blessed One who delighted in it. It also equals in gematria “intermediate” (אמצעית), for it is intermediary between us and the Blessed One, to give us life and merit for a world that is entirely good, for the upper and lower Garden of Eden, and to save us

[1] These refer to the divine partzufim (personas) of Abba and Imma, corresponding to the sefirot of Chokhmah (Wisdom) and Binah (Understanding) in kabbalistic thought.
[2] This refers to the middle line of the kabbalistic Tree of Life diagram, consisting of the sefirot Keter, Tiferet, Yesod, and Malkhut, representing divine balance and harmony.
[3] Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) is the sixth sefirah, associated with balance, truth, and compassion. It is often represented by multiple colors to indicate its harmonizing nature.
[4] This refers to the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation), often called “Tzaddik” or “Righteous One” in kabbalistic literature, which channels divine flow from the upper sefirot to Malkhut.

[i] The double Yud in the word וייצר (formed) is a classic rabbinic observation (Genesis Rabbah 14:9) interpreted kabbalistically to indicate formation for both worlds and suggesting the dual nature of human composition.
[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic association of the term “kol” (all) with the sefirah of Yesod, known as “Tzaddik” (Righteous One), which channels divine flow to Malkhut.
[iii] The gematria (numerical value) of תורה (Torah = 611) is equated with אוצר שדי (treasure of Shaddai = 611), suggesting Torah as God’s hidden treasure.
[iv] תורה (Torah = 611) is equated with אמצעית (intermediate = 611), emphasizing Torah’s role as mediator between humans and God.

ולהצילנו מרדת שחת ח״ו. וכבר ציינתי לך לעיל מקום דרושי ג״ע וגיהנם ועה״ב ותחייה בציוני. והרמב״ן בשער הגמול[i] כבר ידעת שיחד שער ההוא לדרושים אלו והובאו דבריו בקצור בפרק ח׳ להרמב״ם מהלכות תשובה. והיה כל מבקש ה׳ ימצא במקומות אלו מבוקשו מלבד מה שהוספנו בפרקים חלו. ברוך המרומם על כל ברכה ותהלה:[ii]

from descending to destruction, God forbid. I have already marked for you above the location of the discourses on the Garden of Eden, Gehenna, the World to Come, and resurrection in my notations. And as for Nachmanides in "The Gate of Reward," you already know that he dedicated that gate to these discourses, and his words are brought in brief in chapter 8 of Maimonides' Laws of Repentance. And let everyone who seeks the LORD find what they seek in these places, besides what we have added in these chapters. Blessed is He who is exalted above all blessing and praise.

190R

195R

פרק מ״א

Chapter 41

לבך תשית נא לדברים ואל יליזו מנגד עיניך כי בזה תדע ותבין איך משפטי ה׳ אמת צדקו יחדיו בדינו של נחש יצר הרע שבאדם[iii] ובדינו של הגוף ובדינה של הנשמה ואיך מרכיב חגר על סומא ודנם יחד:[v iv]

Please set your heart to these words[1] and do not let them depart from before your eyes, for through this you will know and understand how the judgments of the LORD are true and righteous together in the judgment of the serpent—the evil inclination within man—and in the judgment of the body, and in the judgment of the soul, and how He places a lame per-

5R

[1]The opening phrase is a direct appeal to the reader to pay close attention, using biblical language that echoes similar exhortations in wisdom literature.

[i]"Sha'ar HaGemul" (Gate of Reward) is Nachmanides' treatise on the afterlife, reflecting medieval Jewish views on rewards and punishments after death.

[ii]Cf. Tikkun 53 of Tikkunei Zohar — The author quotes this passage to emphasize the spiritual importance of Torah study as protection against spiritual destruction and the fires of Gehenna. | Cf. Genesis 2:7-9 — The author reinterprets these creation verses kabbalistically, seeing the Garden as the Written Torah, Eden as Torah's delights, and the man as the human soul placed in this spiritual garden. | Cf. Nachmanides' Sha'ar HaGemul (Gate of Reward) — The author references this work as an authoritative source on the afterlife concepts he has been discussing, directing readers there for more comprehensive treatment of these subjects. | Cf. Proverbs 3:16 — This verse is applied to Torah specifically (rather than wisdom generally) to emphasize Torah's dual benefits: spiritual longevity through righteousness and material prosperity through divine blessing.

[iii]The author identifies the biblical serpent with the evil inclination (yetzer hara), a common interpretation in rabbinic and kabbalistic thought. This creates a tripartite division of human experience: the body, the soul, and the evil inclination that connects them.

[iv]This is a reference to a famous Talmudic parable (Sanhedrin 91b) about divine judgment. In the parable, a king's orchard was guarded by two watchmen—one blind and one lame. The lame man sat on the blind man's shoulders to steal fruit, and each claimed innocence because of their disability. The king judged them together by placing the lame man on the blind man's shoulders. This illustrates how God judges the body (blind) and soul (lame) together, despite their separate claims.

[v]Cf. Talmud Bavli, Sanhedrin 91b — The author draws on this famous Talmudic parable to explain how God judges the body (compared to the blind man) and the soul (compared to the lame man) together. The evil inclination (serpent) is added as a third component in this judgment system. | Cf. Genesis 3 — The 'serpent' here is identified with the evil inclination (yetzer hara), connecting the primordial tempter with the internal inclination toward sin that exists within every person. | Cf. Psalms 19:10 — This verse is quoted to emphasize that God's judgments, though complex in dealing with the tripartite nature of human existence (body, soul, and evil inclination), are ultimately just and harmonious.

son upon a blind one and judges them together.[1]

בעת שאדם יפשוט גופו ויוצא
מעולמו אז דנין אותו לפניו
מדעתו ושומעים טענותיו ורואה
שאין ממש בדבריו והוא טוען
האשה אשר נתת עמדי הגוף
הזה וטבעו הרע. והגוף משיב
[i]באימה הנחש השיאני והיינו
סטרא דשמאלא וכל בחותיו
המטעים והקב״ה גוזר על הנחש
שיתעכל בגיהנם עד שתטהר
הנשמה מחלאת טנופת החטא ושם
כלים כל המשחיתים שנבראו
בחטא האדם והיינו ארור אתה
תקבל השפעת זיעת חיות הקדש
והמותרות והקללות וכח הדינים
הקשים הנשפעים משם וכל
הפגם שגרמת אתה האדם בכל
הבהמה וחית השדה שהם בחות
קדושים הנפגמים בעונותיך אתה
תקבל כל המותר והדין והקללה
כדכתיב ונשא השעיר עליו את
כל עונותם [ii]אל ארץ גזרה אל
גיהנם שם יחולו כל אותם הדינים
והעונשים ומתהוה מהם מדרגות
צואה רותחת כי הם טמאים
ומוסרחים יותר מהאחרים ובזה
המדרגות העליונות הנפגמות
מחטאת הנשמה הזאת נטהרת
ובזה טוב לה לנשמה הזאת כי לא
תדחה כבראשונה. הנה כי נברא
גיהנם לצרף הנשמות ולטוב

When a person sheds his body and departs from his world, he is then judged before himself with his own knowledge,[2] and his arguments are heard. He sees that there is no substance to his words, and he claims, “The woman whom You gave to be with me”—this body and its evil nature. And the body responds with dread, “The serpent deceived me”—meaning the left side and all its deceptive powers.[3] The Holy One, blessed be He, then decrees upon the serpent that it shall be consumed in Gehenna until the soul is purified from the filth of sin’s defilement. There, all the destructive forces created through human sin are destroyed. 10R 15R 20R

This is the meaning of “cursed are you”: you shall receive the influence of the sweat of the holy Chayot,[4] the excess, the curses, and the power of harsh judgments that flow from there. And all the damage that you, O human, have caused to all the beasts and animals of the field—which are holy powers[5] damaged by your sins—you shall receive all the excess, judgment, and curse, as it is written: “And the goat shall bear upon itself all their iniquities to a desolate land,” to Gehenna, where all those judgments and punishments shall take effect. From them are formed levels of boiling excrement, for they are more impure and putrid than the others. Through this, the higher levels that were damaged by this soul’s sin are purified, and this is good for this soul, as it will not be rejected as before. 25R 30R 35R

Behold, Gehenna was created to refine souls and for their benefit, and the dust—which is the sub-

[1] This passage serves as an introduction to the detailed explanation that follows in the text about how God judges the three components of human existence after death: the evil inclination (identified with the primordial serpent), the body, and the soul. The parable of the blind and lame man illustrates how entities that might try to blame each other can be judged as a single unit.

[2] The Hebrew ‘לפניו מדעתו’ carries a nuance that one’s judgment occurs with full self-awareness and participation, not simply as an external process imposed upon the person.

[3] In Kabbalah, ‘the left side’ (סטרא דשמאלא) refers to the forces of divine judgment, restriction, and sometimes impurity, as opposed to ‘the right side’ which represents mercy and expansion.

[4] In Jewish mystical thought, the Chayot are angelic beings described in Ezekiel’s vision. The ‘sweat’ metaphorically represents the spiritual byproduct or overflow of divine energies that becomes transformed into judgment when filtered through lower realms.

[5] In kabbalistic interpretation, animals symbolize various spiritual forces or divine attributes (sefirot) that are ‘damaged’ when humans sin, as all creation is interconnected in a cosmic unity.

[i] This quotes Eve’s response in Genesis 3:13, establishing a parallel between the biblical narrative and the spiritual dynamics at judgment after death.

[ii] Reference to the Yom Kippur scapegoat ritual from Leviticus 16:22, using this biblical ritual as a metaphor for how the evil inclination (the serpent) bears the punishment for the soul’s sins.

להם[i] ועפר שהוא חומר האדם
הנברא מן העפר[ii]

stance of the human who was created from dust. 40R

כדכתיב כי עפר אתה ונאמר
עליו ועפר תאכל כל ימי חייך
כי הולך הגוף שהוא מעור הנחש
בלבוש הזה להתעכל עפרו
ואמרו שם ובמות הנחש כלים
ונאבדים שם והיינו כל ימי חייך
אין לך קיום ושמירה רק כל זמן
שיש לך עפר זה לאכלו וכיון
שהעפר כלה חייו כלים על דרך
הכסיל חובק את ידיו ואוכל
את בשרו דוקא לא חלק הנפש
ח״ו.[iii] ואהבה הגדולה אשר אל
החומר עם יצה״ר בעה״ז בעודו
בחיים. אחר המות נפלה איבה
ביניהם הנחש שונא את הגוף
אבל מה יעשה שהוא משולח
מלמעלה כאשר אמרנו על פסוק
ואוכל את בשרו ולזה ואיבה
אשית בינך ובין האשה החומר
רואה שהחיצוני אשר אהבתו
אהבה עזה ונמשך אחריו בא
עתה לגבות את כל אשר שמע
לעצתו ויהפך לו לאויב שכן
דרך החיצוני ששונא ומשחית
לאוהב אותו וכפי גודל אהבת
האדם עליו כן יגביר עליו חצים

As it is written "for you are dust" it was said of him "and dust you shall eat all the days of your life," for the body, which is from the serpent's skin in this garment, goes to have its dust consumed.[1] And they said there: "When the serpent dies, they are consumed and lost there." This means "all the days of your life"—you have no existence or protection except for as long as you have this dust to consume. Once the dust is gone, his life is finished, as in "The fool folds his hands and consumes his own flesh"—specifically the flesh, not the soul portion, God forbid. 45R 50R

The great love that exists between the material body and the evil inclination in this world while one is alive—after death, enmity falls between them. The serpent hates the body,[2] but what can it do? It is dispatched from above, as we said regarding the verse "and consumes his flesh." Therefore, "I will put enmity between you and the woman." The material body sees that the external force, which it loved with intense love and followed, now comes to collect payment for all the advice it heeded, and turns into an enemy. For such is the way of the external force: it hates and destroys those who love it, and according to the magnitude of a person's love for it,[3] so it strengthens arrows and stones of the bow against 55R 60R 65R

[1]The Hebrew 'להתעכל עפרו' literally means 'to have its dust digested/consumed,' referring to the decomposition process of the body in the grave.
[2]This describes a significant reversal in the relationship between the evil inclination (serpent) and the body. During life, they were allies against the soul; after death, they become enemies.
[3]This presents a mystical principle of divine judgment where the intensity of punishment corresponds exactly to the degree of attachment to evil during life—a spiritual 'measure for measure.'

[i]This presents a redemptive view of Gehenna (Jewish concept of purgatory/hell) as primarily purificatory rather than punitive, emphasizing that its ultimate purpose is for the benefit of souls.
[ii]Cf. Genesis 3:12-13 — The author uses the dialogue from Genesis as a template for the spiritual tribunal that occurs at death, where the soul blames the body, and the body blames the evil inclination (represented by the serpent). | Cf. Leviticus 16:22 — The author draws a parallel between the scapegoat ritual and the function of Gehenna, suggesting that just as the scapegoat carried away Israel's sins to a desolate place, so too the evil inclination bears punishment in Gehenna, cleansing the soul of its defilements. | Cf. Zohar III:152a — The author elaborates on the Zoharic concept that when a person dies, their soul, body, and evil inclination each try to shift blame onto the others, but ultimately they are judged together as a unit. | Cf. Sanhedrin 91b — Though not explicitly mentioned, this passage echoes the famous Talmudic parable where a king punishes both a blind man and a lame man who together stole from his orchard, despite each claiming inability to commit the crime alone. Similarly, the text describes how body, soul, and evil inclination are all held accountable despite attempting to shift blame.
[iii]This is an abbreviation for "chas v'shalom" (Heaven forbid), indicating the author's concern to make clear that the destruction in the grave affects only the physical body, not the soul.

ואבני קשת. על דרך דאמור
רבנן טב לביש לא תעביד ובישא
לא ימטי לך על זה אמר ואיבה
70 אשית בינך ובין האשה שיש איבה
אל החיצוני עם האדם שלא יהיה
רוצה לשלוט בגוף אלא בנפש.
והנשמה נמלטה למעלה מידו
לטהרה[i] והגוף החיצוני לא היה
75 רוצה בו זהו כוונת ואיבה אשית
בינך ובין האשה ובין זרעך ובין
זרעה. בין זרעך שזרעת במעשיך
עמו ובין זרעה שזרע במעשיו
עמך ואלו ואלו כלים יחד בקבר
80 בדיניו הוא ישופך ראש שאפי׳
כחות דינו כלים בו. ואחר דין
הקבר ששקט דיניו האדם מזומן
לחלוץ עצמות ולתחייה[ii] שהוא
כליון הנחש ואפי׳ בחלק העליון
85 שבו מצד חוצה. ואתה תשופנו
עקב שעתה הוא נושכו באחרית
כחות החומר בסופו עקב מעשיו
במספר לבד זהו גזרת החצוני
הנגמר שם מיד. עד כאן דינו של
90 נחש יצה״ר שבגוף האדם.[iii][iv]

him.

As the Sages said: "Do no good to the wicked, and evil will not befall you." Concerning this He said, "I will put enmity between you and the 70R
woman"—there is enmity between the external force and the human, as it does not wish to dominate the body but rather the soul. The soul escapes upward from its hand for purification, and the external body does not desire it. This is the meaning of "I will put 75R
enmity between you and the woman, between your seed and her seed"—between your seed that you sowed through your deeds with him, and between her seed that she sowed through her deeds with you. And both of these are consumed together in the 80R
grave through his judgments.

"He shall bruise your head"—even the powers of his judgment are consumed by him. And after the judgment of the grave, when his judgments are quieted, the person is prepared for the resurrection of 85R
the bones, which is the destruction of the serpent, even in its highest part from the external side.

"And you shall bruise his heel"—for now it bites him at the end of the material powers, at his conclusion, the heel of his deeds, in number alone. This 90R
is the decree of the external force that is completed there immediately. Thus far is the judgment of the serpent, the evil inclination within the human body.[1]

[1] This final sentence indicates that the text has only addressed the first component of the threefold judgment that occurs after death. In subsequent passages, the author will discuss the judgment of the body itself and then of the soul.

[i] This presents the key kabbalistic concept that death is actually a means of purification for the soul, allowing it to escape the grasp of the evil inclination.

[ii] The phrase "chalatz atzamot" (resurrection of bones) refers to the future bodily resurrection, a fundamental Jewish belief that is here framed as the ultimate victory over the evil inclination.

[iii] This concluding line indicates that the preceding text was specifically about the judgment of the serpent/evil inclination, and suggests the author will now move on to discuss the judgment of other aspects of human existence.

[iv] Cf. Genesis 3:14 — The verse "and dust you shall eat all the days of your life" is quoted directly from God's curse to the serpent in Eden, establishing the biblical foundation for the kabbalistic interpretation that follows. | Cf. Genesis 3:15 — The verse "I will put enmity between you and the woman, between your seed and her seed" is quoted directly, but interpreted in a mystical sense where the "woman" represents the physical body and the serpent represents the evil inclination. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 4:5 — The verse "The fool folds his hands and consumes his own flesh" is quoted to illustrate the self-destructive relationship between the body and the evil inclination, showing how scriptural wisdom literature is reinterpreted in kabbalistic terms. | Cf. Talmud — The quote "Do no good to the wicked, and evil will not befall you" is presented as rabbinic wisdom ("as the Sages said") and used to support the author's argument about the dangers of associating with evil forces. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4, Chapters 36-38 — These chapters explore the metaphysical structure of the Garden of Eden and Gehenna (Hell), providing the broader cosmological framework for understanding the soul's journey described in this passage.

דין הגוף עליו שהוא מיוחס
לאשה[i] נאמר הרבה ארבה
עצבונך שם בקבר כי נפשו עליו
תאבל והרונך שם מוליד כל
מה שנתעבר בעבירות העבירות
וזה יהיה פי׳ טול מה שנתת בי
וגו׳ ימים הראשונים חבלי לידה
יש לגוף כי מקשקשים בתוכו
כל עבירות העבירות ותחיל
תזעק בחבליו וזהו דין קשה של
חבוט הקבר ושם הנשמה נכנסת
אל הגוף אמנם אינו נכנסת כמו
שהוא בחיים חיותו שא״כ מה
יתרון תחיית המתים.[ii] אלא בזמן
שאדם חי הנשמה בגופו מחייה
אותו אמנם בקבר מכניסים
הנשמה בגוף באשה עוברה
כעובר בתוך האשה הגוף הזה
הוא מתעבר ושם הנשמה נעצבת
בדיני הגוף. והיינו והרונך קשה
רמה למת בבשרו כמחט בבשר
החי ואפי׳ מספרי התולעים
גוזרים מלמעלה לפי באשו
וצחנתו אשר פעל ועשה וגרם
בחייו ומספר קושי הרמה בבשר
כמספר מעשיו הקשים ועם היות
שאין לך אדם שאינו נדון ברמה
ותולעה אינו שוה לכל בחינת
קושי הזה שיש מי שיקשה לו מאד
ויש מי שמרגיש אבל לא כ״כ ויש
מי שאינו מרגיש. ואמרו בתוס׳
על מאמר שאין רמה שולטת
בצדיקים[iii] לפי שתשמישי קדושה
יש בהם כמו כן קדושה ומדרגה

Concerning the judgment of the body, which is associated with the feminine, it is said: "I will greatly multiply your pain" there in the grave, for one's soul mourns over it. "And your conception"—there it gives birth to all that was conceived in the turbidity of transgressions. This is the meaning of "take what you placed in me, etc." In the first days there are birth pangs for the body, as all the turbidity of transgressions rattles within it, and it writhes and cries out in its pangs. This is the severe judgment of the "Beating of the Grave" (Chibut HaKever[1]). There the soul enters the body, but it does not enter as it did during life, for if so, what advantage would there be in the resurrection of the dead? Rather, when a person is alive, the soul in his body gives it life, but in the grave, the soul is placed in the body like a pregnant woman—like an embryo within the woman. This body becomes impregnated, and there the soul is distressed in the judgments of the body.

This is the meaning of "and your conception"—the worm is as painful to the dead in his flesh as a needle in living flesh.[2] Even the number of worms is decreed from above according to the stench and putrefaction that he caused and created through his actions in life. The severity of the worm's pain in the flesh corresponds to the number of his harsh deeds. And although there is no person who is not judged by worms and maggots, this hardship is not equal for all. There are those for whom it is very difficult, those who feel it but not as intensely, and those who do not feel it at all.[3]

The Tosafot commented on the statement that "worms do not have power over the righteous," explaining that just as sacred objects contain holiness

[1] Chibut HaKever is a concept in Jewish eschatology describing a form of purification or judgment that the soul experiences immediately after death. The author is elaborating on this traditional concept with a detailed kabbalistic interpretation.

[2] This vivid image comes from Talmudic discussions about whether the dead feel pain during decomposition. The author takes this quite literally and develops it into a comprehensive theory of post-mortem punishment.

[3] The author is establishing a nuanced system of post-mortem judgment where the severity of decomposition-related suffering is precisely calibrated to one's sins, while maintaining that even the relatively righteous (except for the completely righteous) experience some form of this judgment.

[i] The author is using the gendered symbolism of Kabbalah, where the body is associated with the feminine principle (as is the divine attribute of Malkhut), while the soul is associated with the masculine principle.

[ii] This is a key theological point distinguishing between the soul's presence in the body during life versus during the post-mortem judgment. The author is explaining that resurrection must involve a fundamentally different relationship between body and soul than existed during earthly life.

[iii] This refers to a Talmudic tradition (Shabbat 152b) that the bodies of the righteous do not

מצד ההנאה והתועלת שקבל הקדושה מהם ולכן תשמישי קדושה נגנזים והרחיב בזה הביאור החכם בס׳ הפרדס בשער המציאות[i] יעויין שם. והכל לפי מעשיו וצרכו בדין כי הכל במדה ובמשקל בדעות של אל דעות וכפי צורך הגוף הזה בדין להטיבו באחריתו והיינו בעצב תלדי בנים שם תלדי בנים זרים כפי חשבון מעשיך[ii]

and spiritual levels derived from the benefit and advantage that holiness received from them, so too the bodies of the righteous. This is why sacred objects are stored away. The sage elaborated on this explanation in the book Pardes, in the Gate of Existence[1]—see there. Everything is according to one's deeds and what one needs in judgment, for all is measured and weighed in the knowledge of the God of knowledge, and according to what this body needs in judgment to improve its end. This is the meaning of "in pain you shall bear children"—there you will give birth to strange children according to the reckoning of your deeds.

130R 135R 140R

ואל אישך תשוקתך כמה ישתוקק הגוף אל הנשמה להחליץ עצמותיו ומספרי הימים שנגזר שיתפרדו איש מאחיו עד יתוקן הגוף ותתקן הנשמה מלמעלה ותתעלה לסוד הצחצחות ותחזור אח״כ ותחלוץ. העצמות כל יום מימי הפרוד הזה יראו לו אלף שנים[iii] עד שינוחו דיניו ויצא

And your desire shall be for your husband"[2]—how greatly will the body yearn for the soul to strengthen its bones. And the number of days decreed for them to be separated from each other, until the body is rectified and the soul is rectified from above and ascends to the mystery of the spiritual radiances, and afterward returns to strengthen the bones.[3] Each day of this separation will appear to him as a thousand years, until his judgments are at rest and the body

145R

[1]This refers to Pardes Rimmonim (Orchard of Pomegranates) by Moses Cordovero, a systematic exposition of Kabbalah. The author is drawing on Cordovero's explanation of how physical objects can become vessels of holiness to explain why the bodies of the righteous might be immune to decomposition.

[2]This is a quotation from Genesis 3:16, part of God's words to Eve after the sin in Eden. The author reinterprets this verse as describing the relationship between body and soul rather than between woman and man.

[3]The Hebrew term 'chalitzut' (strengthening) is related to 'chalatz' (to draw out, strengthen) and carries connotations of revival and resurrection. In this context, it refers to the revitalization of the physical body at resurrection.

decompose after death. The author is explaining this as being related to the concept of 'tashmishei kedushah' (objects used for sacred purposes), which retain holiness and must be treated with special reverence.

[i]This is a reference to 'Pardes Rimmonim' (Orchard of Pomegranates), the systematic Kabbalistic work by Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), specifically the section on the nature of existence.

[ii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 38 — This passage continues the book's exploration of the post-mortem experience, detailing the specific judgment of the body as distinct from the judgment of the evil inclination discussed in the previous passage. | Cf. Genesis 3:16 — The author creatively reinterprets God's curse to Eve as applying to the body's post-mortem experience, with the 'pain' and 'conception' now understood as the spiritual suffering the body undergoes in the grave. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 18b — The author draws on this Talmudic concept but develops it into a full mystical framework where the severity of decomposition is precisely calibrated to one's sins. | Cf. Zohar III:151a — The author is expanding on the Zoharic concept of Chibut HaKever, explaining it as a process where the soul must witness the body's decomposition as part of divine judgment. | Cf. Sefer Pardes by Moses Cordovero — The author references Cordovero's work to support the idea that the bodies of the righteous are immune to decomposition due to having been vessels for holiness.

[iii]This refers to the kabbalistic concept that time is experienced differently in spiritual realms. The phrase 'a thousand years' draws on Psalm 90:4, 'For a thousand years in Your sight are like a day.'

הגוף להבעל מן הנשמה ואז לא
תהיה חזרתה לתוכו כבראשונה
בימים הראשונים להשפט יחד
רק תרד לצחצח סוד רוחניות
העצמות וזהו ואל אישך תשוקתך
והענין הזה תלוי בסוף כי אחר
שנח דין הקבר אז מתחילין דין
הנשמה להיות נטהרה בנהר
דינור עד שתתעלה לג״ע עליון
וכבר בארנו למעלה שמץ קצת
ממה תתענג שם. ואחרי עלותה
משם מחלץ העצמות ומזיינם
כדכתיב והשביע בצחצחות
נפשך כשיגיע זמן שהנפש תשבע
בצחצחות והיינו שלשה צח נפש
צחות רוח ונשמה[i] מיד ועצמותיך
יחליץ והיית כגן רוה וגו׳ וזה
כוונת והוא ימשל בך הנשמה
הנקרא הוא שממקום הנעלה
מחצבה[ii] העקר תלוי בה כי עד
שתזכה אל הצחיות האלו לא
יזכה הגוף אל החליצות ע״כ הוא
מדין הגוף:[iii]

emerges to be possessed by the soul. And then its return into the body will not be as at first, in the early days to be judged together, but rather it descends to purify the mystery of the spirituality of the bones. And this is [the meaning of] "your desire shall be for your husband." This matter depends on the end, for after the judgment of the grave is at rest, then the judgment of the soul begins as it is purified in the River of Fire,[1] until it ascends to the upper Garden of Eden. And we have already explained above a small hint of how it will delight there. And after its ascent from there, it strengthens the bones and adorns them, as it is written, "He will satisfy your soul with brightness," when the time comes that the soul will be satisfied with brightnesses, which are the three brightnesses—brightness of Nefesh, brightness of Ruach, and brightness of Neshamah—immediately "and your bones He will strengthen," "and you shall be like a watered garden," etc. This is the meaning of "and he shall rule over you"—the soul, which is called "he," whose origin is from the hidden place, the essence depends on it, for until it merits these purities, the body will not merit strengthening. This concludes the judgment of the body.

פרק מ״ב

Chapter 42

כי מצאתי בדרושי גורי האר״י[iv] I found in the writings of the disciples of the

[1] Nahar Dinur (River of Fire) is a concept from Daniel 7:10, developed in Kabbalah as a purifying river through which souls pass after death to cleanse them of remaining impurities before entering higher spiritual realms.

[i] The author creates a threefold interpretation of the word 'tzachtzachot' (brightnesses/radiances) in Isaiah 58:11, connecting it to the three traditional levels of the soul: Nefesh (vital soul), Ruach (spirit), and Neshamah (higher soul).

[ii] This phrase refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'quarry of the soul' (machtzav ha-neshamah), the divine source from which souls originate. The soul's higher origin gives it authority over the body.

[iii] Cf. Genesis 3:16 — This passage provides a kabbalistic interpretation of the biblical verse addressed to Eve after the fall. The author reframes this verse as describing the relationship between body and soul after death, rather than husband and wife. The desire of the body for the soul and the soul's rulership over the body become metaphors for the process of resurrection and the soul's purification. | Cf. Isaiah 58:11 — The author draws on this prophetic verse about divine restoration to describe the ultimate resurrection process. The 'brightness' (tzachtzachot) becomes a technical term referring to spiritual radiance that purifies the three levels of the soul before resurrection. | Cf. Earlier sections of Ma'avar Yabok — The author refers to earlier discussions in the book about the soul's experience of delight in the upper Garden of Eden, indicating this text is part of a larger systematic exploration of the afterlife journey.

[iv] The term 'gurei ha-ARI' refers to the disciples of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the ARI), the great 16th century kabbalist who revolutionized Jewish mysticism. His teachings were primarily transmitted through his students rather than through his own writings.

אחרי הקבורה באים ד׳ מלאכים
המשפילים הקבר ומעמיקים
אותו בארץ כגובה קומת האדם
וכדאיתא במדרש ולהיות כי
הקליפה קשורה עם הנשמה ועם
הגוף לכן מחברים אותם יחד
ואז אוחזים אותם המלאכים
באותו האדם כל אחד מן הקצה
שלו ומנערים אותו וחובטים
אותו במקלות של ברזל כדרך
שחובט אדם כסותו ומנערו
להסיר ממנו העפר הדבק בו
ולכן צריכים להעמיק הקבר
כדי שיהיה מקום לצערו ולחבטו
וכך הם עושים עד שתפרד מעט
מעט אותה קליפה מן האדם
עד שנעקרת לגמרי וזהו פירוש
חבוט הקבר[i] ממש. ואמנם לא כל
האנשים שוים כנזכר כי הצדיקים
אשר עשו מעשים טובים בחייהם
היו חובטים עצמן מתפרדת
קליפה זו מעליהם ע״י היסורין
והצער שסובלין בחייהם וע״י
התורה שמתשת גופו של אדם.
ברם להפרידה בחיים לגמרי
א״א ואין איש ניצול מחבוט
הקבר אך הרשעים צריכים
טרחא יתירה. ואמר האר״י
משם חכם גדול שכל הנקבר
ביום ששי אחר ה׳ שעות ביום
והשעה החמישית בכלל אינו
רואה חבוט הקבר כי קדושת
השבת מפרידה ממנו בלי צער
וזה סוד יום הששי ה׳ יתירה[ii] כי

ARI[1] that after burial, four angels come and lower the grave, deepening it in the earth to the height of a person's stature, as mentioned in the Midrash. Since the kelipah[2] [negative spiritual force] is bound with the soul and the body, they join them together. Then the angels take hold of the person, each from his end, and shake him and beat him with iron rods, just as a person beats his garment and shakes it to remove the dust clinging to it. Therefore, they need to deepen the grave[3] so there will be room to cause him pain and beat him. They do this until that kelipah gradually separates from the person until it is completely uprooted—this is the literal meaning of Chibut HaKever [the Beating of the Grave].

However, not all people are equal in this matter, for the righteous who performed good deeds during their lives were already beating themselves, separating this kelipah from themselves through the sufferings and pain they endured in their lifetime and through Torah study, which weakens a person's body. Yet it is impossible to separate it completely during life, and no one escapes Chibut HaKever, though the wicked require extra effort. The ARI said in the name of a great sage that anyone buried on Friday after the fifth hour of the day (including the fifth hour) does not experience Chibut HaKever, because the sanctity of the Sabbath separates it from him without pain. This is the secret of "the sixth day" with the additional letter hei, for from that time onward it is truly the Sabbath eve.

If a person during his lifetime could attain knowledge of the name of that kelipah that is with him—how it is called—and thus understand why his name is called so, he would know the location of the spir-

[1] The original Hebrew phrase 'gurei ha-ARI' specifically refers to the students of Rabbi Isaac Luria (1534-1572), known by the acronym ARI (the Lion). These disciples were responsible for recording and transmitting his revolutionary kabbalistic teachings.

[2] Kelipah (plural: kelipot) literally means 'shell' or 'husk' in Hebrew. In Kabbalistic thought, particularly Lurianic Kabbalah, kelipot are negative spiritual forces that conceal divinity. They are believed to attach themselves to humans through sinful actions and require separation from the soul after death.

[3] This description of angels deepening the grave for the purpose of Chibut HaKever should be understood metaphysically rather than physically. It represents the spiritual space needed for the soul's purification process.

[i] Chibut HaKever (the Beating of the Grave) is a post-mortem process described in kabbalistic and some rabbinic texts. It is understood as a purification that souls undergo shortly after burial, separating negative spiritual elements from the soul.

[ii] This refers to the additional letter hei in the phrase 'the sixth day' (יום הששי) in Genesis 1:31, where the definite article is used only for this day among the days of creation. In Jewish tradition, this extra hei alludes to the special sanctity of Friday afternoon as it approaches the Sabbath.

מאז ולמעלה הוא ערב שבת ממש. ואם האדם בהיותו בחיים היה יכול להשיג ולידע שם של אותה קליפה שעמו איך נקראת ואז משיג לידע למה נקרא שמו כך בזה היה יודע מקום הפגם ומציאות תקונו איך הוא ואז היתה נפרדת ממנו אפי׳ בחיים ולא היה נצרך אל חבוט הקבר ובזה נבין ענין הרשעים שאמרו במדרש שאינן יודעים שמם ולכן מכין אותם כי אם היו יודעים היו יכולים להסירה ולהפרידה יותר בקלות. עתה יהיו דברינו בדין הנשמה שדינה באחרונה והכל בא גלוי בפסוק ולאדם אמר כי שמעת לקול אשתך שהוא החומר והגוף ותאכל מן העץ דהיינו היות נמשך אחר הנאות העוה״ז במותרות ורוב אכילות ולרבות במשגל בלא זמן המיוחד לו וכדומה כי מהם בא אל האסורות שטפות זרות מטמאים אותו ומן ההיתר בא אל האסור וכן על זה הדרך בכל תענוגי בני האדם שמתהוים מהם כחות שגורמים לו שעובר על לא תעשה ומונע עצמו מן העשה וזהו ותאכל מן העץ אשר צויתיך זו היא שבועה שמשביעין הנשמה בבואה לעולם כי שמעה קול אלה האומר אליו לא תאכל ממנו הנה המקום העליון אשר שם היתה נשמתך תקועה כתוב לחיים בפרגוד עולם הכסא עתה נמחק משם הצורה ההיא והיא במקומה פגומה והמקום ההוא החסר עבורך המתקומם בו נובע לך דין ופגם עד שהנשמה תקבל כל עונשיה ותהיה ראויה לחזור אל משכן כבודה. ואם הצורה נמחקת משם מכל וכל ח״ו בעונות שיש בהם כרת וכדומה אוי לו שכבר נטרד מארץ החיים וכמה פרכוסין תפרכס עד

itual blemish and how to rectify it. Then it would separate from him even during life, and he would not need Chibut HaKever. This helps us understand the matter of the wicked, who according to the Midrash do not know their name, and therefore they are beaten, for if they knew, they could remove and separate it more easily.

Now we will discuss the judgment of the soul, which is judged last. Everything is revealed in the verse: "To Adam He said, 'Because you heeded your wife's voice'"—which refers to the material and the body—"and ate from the tree," meaning being drawn after the pleasures of this world through excesses, overeating, and excessive sexual relations outside their proper time, and similar matters. For from these one comes to forbidden things—strange flows defile him, and from the permitted one comes to the forbidden. So it is with all human pleasures, from which forces develop that cause one to transgress negative commandments and refrain from fulfilling positive ones.

"And you ate from the tree which I commanded you [not to eat from]"—this refers to the oath that the soul is made to swear[1] when it enters the world, for it heard the voice of the oath saying, "Do not eat from it." Behold, the supernal place where your soul was implanted, inscribed for life in the curtain of the Throne world, now has that form erased from there, and it is blemished in its place. That place, which is deficient because of you and is aroused against you, issues judgment and blemish until the soul receives all its punishments and becomes worthy to return to its glorious dwelling. And if the form is completely erased from there, God forbid, through sins that carry the penalty of spiritual excision and the like, woe to him, for he has already been expelled from the land of the living, and how many convulsions he will experience until his return. If it is not erased from there but only the vitality and spirituality included in its place are blemished, with higher permission judgment is decreed for him until the form is inscribed there for supernal life. Through this, the wise will understand the reward of the righteous and the intermediate.

"Cursed is the ground because of you"—you

[1] This refers to a Talmudic concept (Niddah 30b) that before birth, the soul is made to swear to live righteously, and is taught the entire Torah, though this knowledge is forgotten at birth when an angel touches the infant's upper lip.

שובה. ואם אינה נמחקת משם רק
נפגמת החיות ורוחניות הנכלל
במקומה ברשות עליון קובע
לו דין עד שתכתב שם הצורה
85 לחיים העליונים. ובזה יובן
למשכילים שכרן של צדיקים
ושל בינוניים וכו׳. ארורה
האדמה בעבורך גרמת שבלבלת
היכל מלך בעצבון תאכלנה כל
90 אותם הקללות ומעוטים שגרמת
שם במעשיך הרעים כי שממית
בידים תתפש והיא בהיכלי מלך
מחמת מעשיך בעצבון בדין
גהינם תאכלנה עד שיתעכל כל
95 ימי חייך שם וכל הימים אשר
בחרת לחיות בתאות הגוף ולא
המתה עצמך על דברי תורה.
על דרך מה יעשה אדם ויחיה
ימות אדם כי ימות באהל שם
100 בעצבון תאכלנה ותעכל אותם.
יש נשמה שנגזר עליה טבילה
בעלמא. ויש מי שנגזר עליה
דין שעה ויש שנגזר עליה דין
שלשה ויש דין שבעה ויש דין
105 שלשים ויש דין י״ב חדש הכל
לפי מעשיו ופגמו בשורש נשמתו.
וקוץ ודרדר תצמיח לך עם
היות שאומרים נהר דינור[i] אין
עניינו מאש וטובל ועומד שם
110 תוך האש לבד אלא כמה קוצים
ודרדרים דנים אותו שם הכל
כפי רשעתו במספר ואפי׳ מה
שגרמת אל הכחות החצונים
למרוד ולהטיח נגד הקדושה
115 במעשיך גם מזה תענש וזהו וקוץ
ודרדר תצמיח לך שם ואכלת
את עשב השדה. אח״כ נגזר עליו
שלא יכניס בג״ע ולא יהיה נדון
אלא כך ימים ישב חוץ לג״ע
120 ואינו אוכל בתרומת הקדשים
אלא נזון מעשב מאכל גרוע

caused confusion in the King's palace. "In toil shall you eat of it"—all those curses and diminishments that you caused there through your evil deeds. For "the spider takes hold with her hands, and it is in kings' palaces"—because of your deeds, in toil, 85R
in the judgment of Gehenna,[1] you shall eat of it until all your days there are consumed—all the days that you chose to live in bodily desire and did not mortify yourself over words of Torah. Following the principle of "What should a person do to live? Let 90R
him die"—when "a person dies in a tent," there "in toil shall you eat and consume them."

There is a soul for which merely immersion is decreed. There is one for which an hour's judgment is decreed, and one for which three days' judgment 95R
is decreed, and there is a judgment of seven days, a judgment of thirty days, and a judgment of twelve months—all according to one's deeds and the blemish in the root of one's soul.

"And thorns and thistles shall it bring forth for 100R
you"—although they say "River of Fire," its nature is not merely to immerse and stand there in the fire alone, but rather how many thorns and thistles judge him there, all according to his wickedness in number. Even what you caused to the external forces to rebel 105R
and strike against holiness through your deeds—for this too you will be punished. This is the meaning of "thorns and thistles shall it bring forth for you there," and "you shall eat the herb of the field."

Afterward it is decreed that he shall not enter the 110R
Garden of Eden, and he shall not be judged except for so many days. He sits outside the Garden of Eden and does not eat of the sacred contributions but is nourished from inferior herb food. Then it is decreed that he shall not be healed from his wounds and bites 115R
but shall prolong his illness until he is healed from the crushing blows of the River of Fire, which is the supernal fire of Gehenna. This is the meaning of "By the sweat of your brow shall you eat bread, until you return to the ground from which you were 120R
taken"—until you return to the place from which

[1] Gehenna in Jewish thought is not equivalent to the Christian concept of hell as eternal punishment. Rather, it is understood as a temporary place of purification for the soul, typically lasting no more than twelve months (as mentioned later in this text).

[i] The River of Dinur (River of Fire) appears in the book of Daniel and in mystical literature. It is described as a river of fire through which souls pass for purification after death, removing spiritual impurities before they can ascend to higher realms.

ואח״כ נידונית שלא תתרפא ממכותיה ומנשיכותיה אלא מארכת בחלייה. עד שתתרפא ממחץ מכות נהר דינור שהוא אש גהינם עליון והיינו בוזעת אפך תאכל לחם עד שובך אל האדמה אשר ממנה לוקחת עד שתחזור אל המקום אשר ממנה חוצבה מפני שהכל היה מן העפר [i]עליון עפר קדוש והכל שב אל העפר. כי עפר אתה ואל עפר תשוב. ואל עפר עליון תשוב. וכיון שהנשמה עלתה ותקנה עצמה מה נעשה מן הגוף מיד הנשמה מחלצת הגוף בחליצת עצמות והיינו ויקרא האדם שם אשתו חוה אינה חיה ממש אמנם יש לה קצת חיות מזה כי היא היתה אם כל חי באמת מהחומר והגוף נובע כל שברו. א״כ הגוף ודאי אם לכל חי לנפש שהיא חיה בדירה ידועה בחצר מות ואל הרוח בג״ע של מטה ואל הנשמה בג״ע של מעלה אם לכל במעשיו וראוי שגם לגוף יהיה לו חלק בעדון. ואחר השכר הזה יש לו שכר נוסף שהיא התחיה והיינו ויעש ה׳ אלהים לאדם ולאשתו הנשמה והגוף יחד כתנות עור וילבישם כדכתיב עור ובשר תלבישני ולזה רמז באולי ר״מ דכתב בספרו כתנות [ii]אור שלבוש התחיה יהיה מטל עליון ומאור הקדוש אשרי מי [iii]שעומד בסוד ה׳:

you were hewn,[1] because everything was from the supernal earth, holy dust, and everything returns to the dust. “For dust you are, and to dust shall you return”—and to supernal dust shall you return. 125R

Once the soul has ascended and rectified itself, what happens to the body? Immediately the soul rejuvenates the body through the revival of bones. This is the meaning of “And the man called his wife’s name Eve [Chava]”—she is not literally alive, but 130R she has some vitality from this, for she was truly “the mother of all living”—from the material and the body flows all his reward. Thus the body is certainly mother to all life: to the nefesh [vital soul] that lives in a known dwelling in the Court of Death, to the 135R ruach [spirit] in the lower Garden of Eden, and to the neshamah [higher soul] in the upper Garden of Eden—mother to all according to his deeds. It is fitting that the body too should have a share in the delight. 140R

After this reward, there is an additional reward, which is the resurrection. This is the meaning of “And the LORD God made for Adam and his wife”—the soul and the body together—”garments of skin, and clothed them,” as it is written, “With 145R skin and flesh You clothed me.” This is perhaps what Rabbi Meir alluded to when he wrote in his book “garments of light”[2]—that the garment of resurrection will be from supernal dew and from the holy light. Fortunate is one who stands in the secret 150R of the LORD.

[1] This phrase alludes to Isaiah 51:1, ‘Look to the rock from which you were hewn,’ which is often interpreted as referring to the divine source of the soul. The author is creating a parallel between physical return to dust and the soul’s return to its divine source.

[2] This interpretation, attributed to Rabbi Meir, plays on the similarity between the Hebrew words ‘or’ (אור—light) and ‘or’ (עור—skin), which differ only by their initial letter. This reading suggests that humans were originally clothed in divine light before the Fall and will return to this state in the resurrection.

[i] The concept of ‘supernal dust’ or ‘holy dust’ contrasts with physical earth. In Kabbalah, physical elements have spiritual counterparts in higher worlds. This ‘supernal dust’ represents the divine source from which souls are hewn.

[ii] There is a rabbinic tradition, attributed to Rabbi Meir, that in his Torah scroll, the text of Genesis 3:21 read ‘garments of light’ (כתנות אור with an alef) rather than ‘garments of skin’ (כתנות עור with an ayin). This alternative reading suggests that before the Fall, Adam and Eve were clothed in divine light rather than physical skin.

[iii] Cf. Zohar — The author draws on Zoharic concepts of the soul’s journey after death, particu-

פרק מ״ג

Chapter 43

אמרו בפרק גידול בנים כשישים אדם ידו על ראשו הקטן מתברך שנאמר וישלח ישראל את ידו וכתיב ויברכם ביום ההוא לאמר כי ביד אדם ט״ו פרקים כמנין ט״ו תיבות שבברכת כהנים[i] לומר יחולו על ראשך הברכות שבשלשה פסוקים אלו שהם ט״ו. ומנהג לברך בשבת קדש ובפרט בלילי שבת סוד שבת מלכתא שהם בינה ות״ת למטה במלכות[ii] בנוכר למעלה ובסוד נפש יתירה שעל המברך ומתברך יחולו הברכות ועוד כי אין שטן ופגע רע בשבת שיקטרג על הברכה שנדחו מערב שבת לנוקבא דתהומא רבה[iii] וצורך גבוה הוא לברך האדם בניו בשבת ואם יש לו בת גם היא יברכנה ובפרט בליל שבת והמשכיל יבין מעצמו כי כנים דברינו ואני הרגלתי בעצמי לכוין באברי היד בנוכר. ועוד לכוין בברכת כהנים שבו נכלל בני חיי ומזוני שמוצאם מיו״ד וא״ו ה״א ראשונה של השם שביברכך הוא מציאות היו״ד וביאר מציאות יו״ד וה״א יחד ובישא מציאות יה״ו ומתיבות פסוק ישא מתרבה שם יה״ו לששה

They said in the chapter on raising children that when a person places their hand on the head of a child, the child is blessed, as it is said: “And Israel stretched out his hand” and it is written: “And he blessed them on that day, saying...” For in a person’s 5R
hand there are fifteen joints, corresponding to the fifteen words in the Priestly Blessing, to say that the blessings in these three verses, which are fifteen, shall rest upon your head. And it is customary to bless on the holy Sabbath, especially on Sabbath nights. 10R
This is the secret of the Sabbath Queen, which corresponds to Binah and Tiferet below in Malkhut, as mentioned above. And through the secret of the additional soul that rests upon both the one who blesses and the one who is blessed, the blessings will take 15R
effect. Furthermore, there is no Satan or evil occurrence on the Sabbath to accuse against the blessing, for they are pushed away from Sabbath eve to the great abyss. It is a lofty necessity for a person to bless his sons on the Sabbath, and if he has a daughter, he should bless her as well, especially on Sabbath 20R
night. The wise person will understand on his own that our words are true.

I myself have made it my practice to direct my intention through the parts of the hand as mentioned. 25R
And further to focus on the Priestly Blessing, which includes children, life, and sustenance, whose source is from the Yod, Vav, and first Hei of the Divine Name. In the word “Yevarechecha” (may He bless you) is the manifestation of the Yod. In “Ya’er” (may 30R

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larly regarding the separation of negative spiritual forces from the soul after death | Cf. Genesis 3:17-19 — The author reinterprets God’s curse to Adam as a kabbalistic allegory for the soul’s purification process after death | Cf. Kitvei Ha’ARI — The author explicitly cites the Lurianic Kabbalah tradition as his source for these mystical concepts about post-mortem purification | Cf. Proverbs 30:28 — The author uses this verse as a metaphor for how negative spiritual forces can infiltrate holy places through human misdeeds | Cf. Talmud Berakhot 63b — The author uses this teaching to explain how spiritual self-discipline during life lessens post-mortem suffering | Cf. Job 10:11 — The author uses this verse to support the concept of resurrection, where God will again clothe the soul with a transformed body

[i] The author is referring to the Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim) from Numbers 6:24-26, which in Hebrew contains exactly fifteen words. This creates a mystical correspondence between the fifteen joints in the human hand and the fifteen words of this sacred blessing.

[ii] This reflects the Kabbalistic understanding of Sabbath as a day when the divine emanations align in a particular way: Binah (Understanding) and Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) influencing Malkhut (Kingdom), making it an especially potent time for blessings to flow from the higher spiritual realms to our world.

[iii] According to Kabbalistic tradition, harmful spiritual forces (Satan and his agents) are banished to the ‘great abyss’ on the Sabbath, creating a protected spiritual environment where blessings can flow unimpeded by negative influences.

צרופים[i] ובין כלם הם תשע כזה
י׳ י״ה יה״ו וג׳ אותיות יה״ו
בונות ששה בתים הם תשע תקוני
זעיר שכלם מושפעים בסוד
הברכה לה״א אחרונה מלכות
והנה השם שלם בה ולכן בתפלה
בא אחריה ברכת שים שלום
שהוא אבר השלום המתייחד עם
מלכות להוליד בדומה וכל זה
הוא בכוונת פרקי היד המכוונת
נגד ט״ו אותיות ברכת כהנים
כנזכר אך בפה אני אומר על
המתברך ונחה עליו רוח חכמה
ובינה רוח עצה וגבורה רוח
דעת ויראת ה׳.[ii] ופסוק זה
מכוון מאד למבין אותו לאשורו.
ומלבד כי מעורר רוחניות
הספירות מחכמה ולמטה עוד בו
רמז וסוד להשרות הנשמה והרוח
והנפש[iii]

He shine) is the manifestation of the Yod and Hei together. And in "Yisa" (may He lift) is the manifestation of Yod-Hei-Vav. From the words of the verse "Yisa," the name Yod-Hei-Vav expands into six permutations, and altogether they are nine, like this: Yod, Yod-Hei, Yod-Hei-Vav, and the three letters Yod-Hei-Vav build six structures. These are the nine rectifications of Zeir Anpin, all of which flow through the secret of blessing to the final Hei, which is Malkhut. Thus the Divine Name is completed in it. Therefore, in prayer, the blessing "Sim Shalom" (Establish Peace) follows, which is the organ of peace that unites with Malkhut to produce in its likeness.

All of this is in the intention of the joints of the hand, directed toward the fifteen letters of the Priestly Blessing as mentioned. But verbally, I say over the one being blessed: "And may the spirit of wisdom and understanding rest upon him, the spirit of counsel and might, the spirit of knowledge and fear of the LORD." This verse is very precisely directed for one who understands it properly. Besides awakening the spirituality of the Sefirot from Chokhmah downward, it also contains an allusion and secret to cause the Neshamah, Ruach, and Nefesh to rest upon...

ונפש המשכלת והחיונית על
החמשה חושים[iv] הנרמזים
בפסוק והריחו ביראת ה׳ הבא
אחריו עוד יורה על ההשגה
העתידה שהיא כתנות אור שהיא

And [the phrase also alludes to] the intellectual and vital soul upon the five senses that are alluded to in the verse "And he shall smell with the fear of the LORD" [Isaiah 11:3] that follows it. Furthermore, it teaches about the future perception that is the "gar-

[i]The author explains how the three-letter divine name YHV can be permuted in six different arrangements, and when combined with the individual letters Y, YH, and YHV, creates nine configurations that correspond to cosmic structures within Zeir Anpin (the divine countenance).

[ii]This is a direct quote from Isaiah 11:2, a verse traditionally associated with the messianic figure. By applying this verse to ordinary children during blessing, the author suggests that every child has messianic potential that can be activated through proper blessing.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section on Blessing Children — The author references previous discussions in the text about blessings, indicating this is part of a larger exposition on ritual practices within a mystical framework. | Cf. Genesis 48:14 — The biblical reference to Jacob (Israel) stretching out his hand to bless his grandsons is used as scriptural foundation for the practice of placing hands on children's heads during blessings. | Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — The text refers to the fifteen words of the Priestly Blessing as corresponding to the fifteen joints in the human hand, establishing a mystical correspondence between bodily structure and sacred text. | Cf. Isaiah 11:2 — The verse 'And may the spirit of wisdom and understanding rest upon him...' is quoted as the formula to be recited when blessing children, applying messianic imagery to ordinary ritual blessings. | Cf. Zohar on Sabbath as Queen — The reference to 'Sabbath Queen' (Shabbat Malketa) reflects Zoharic teachings about Sabbath as representing the Sefirah of Malkhut (feminine divine presence), making it an especially potent time for blessings.

[iv]This refers to the intellectual and vital aspects of the soul that operate through the five senses, reflecting a Neoplatonic and medieval Jewish philosophical division of the soul that was integrated into kabbalistic thought.

הנהגת הספירות[i] כפי אשר
היתה מחייבת החכמה עליונה
שבאמת היא נקראת א״ה״ו[ii] והיא
הצפייה הנכספת למשה רבינו
ע״ה שעליה שאל הראני נא את
כבודך להיות כי זכה לקרון
פנים[iii] ופשט בקצת לבושי עור
כדכתיב של נעליך מעל רגליך
ולהיות שבו היה מעורב כתנות
אור עם עור לכך נאמר לו כי לא
יראני האדם וחי בלבושים אלו.
אמנם הוא זכה מחמת הקירון
שבפניו דוקא לצפיית אחורים
שהיא אחורים מהנהגת עץ
החיים[iv] לא צפייה גמורה וכל
זה נרמז בפסוק ונחה עליו רוח
חכמה וגו׳. עוד אמרו שם שלכך
משימים יד על ארון המת. או
על הקבר לבקש רחמים על המת
לפי שבידו של אדם ט״ו פרקים
כמנין ט״ו תיבות שבפסוק יחיו
מתיך וגו׳ ואז יאמרו ונחך ה׳
תמיד וגו׳ ובנו ממך וגו׳ שיזכה
להעלות נפשות הרשעים מתוך
הגהינם[v] מדי עברו שם כנדרש
למעלה עוד יש ביד י״ד פרקים
וידוע סודם הבא בפסוק ועתה
יגדל נא כח אדני כי בבינה יש בה
כ״ח עתים[vi] וזהו ובתבונה משנה
עתים וממנה נמשך הכח למלכות
אדנ״י וממנה מתפשטים כ״ח
מחנות הלבנה העליונה. ומכחה
מתראים בלבנה התחתונה י״ד
ימניים וי״ד שמאליים והם
שתי ידות משולבות אשה אל

ments of light," which is the conduct of the sefirot according to what was necessitated by the supernal wisdom, which in truth is called A-H-V, and it is the vision that Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, longed for, concerning which he asked, "Show me, I pray, Your glory" [Exodus 33:18]. For he merited a shining face and removed some of the garments of skin, as it is written, "Remove your shoes from your feet" [Exodus 3:5]. And since in him was mixed garments of light with skin, therefore it was said to him, "For no man shall see Me and live" [Exodus 33:20] in these garments. However, because of the radiance of his face, he specifically merited a vision of the "back," which is the back [aspect] of the conduct of the Tree of Life, not a complete vision, and all this is alluded to in the verse, "And the spirit of wisdom shall rest upon him" [Isaiah 11:2], etc.

They further said there that this is why we place a hand on the coffin of the deceased, or on the grave to request mercy for the dead, because in a person's hand there are fifteen joints, corresponding to the fifteen words in the verse "Your dead shall live" [Isaiah 26:19], etc. And then they say "And the LORD shall guide you continually" [Isaiah 58:11], etc., and "And they shall build from you" [Isaiah 58:12], etc., that he may merit to raise the souls of the wicked from Gehenna as he passes through there, as explained above.

Furthermore, there are fourteen joints in the hand, and their secret is known to come in the verse "And now, let the power of the Lord be great" [Numbers 14:17], for in Binah there are twenty-eight times, and this is [the meaning of] "and with understanding changes times" [Daniel 2:21], and from it power flows to Malkhut/Adnut, and

[i] The phrase 'garments of light' (kotnot or) contrasts with 'garments of skin' (kotnot or with a different spelling) in Genesis. In kabbalistic thought, Adam and Eve originally had 'garments of light' (spiritual bodies) before the Fall, when they were given 'garments of skin' (physical bodies).

[ii] These Hebrew letters (alef, hei, vav) represent a divine name or abbreviation associated with supernal wisdom in kabbalistic thought.

[iii] This refers to Moses's face shining with divine light after his encounter with God, as described in Exodus 34:29-35.

[iv] This complex kabbalistic concept suggests Moses was granted vision of the 'back' or external aspects of divine governance, but not the complete inner workings of the divine system symbolized by the Tree of Life.

[v] This reflects the Jewish belief that righteous actions by the living, including prayer at gravesites, can elevate the souls of the deceased, even helping to rescue souls from Gehenna (a place of purification after death).

[vi] Twenty-eight 'times' refers to Ecclesiastes 3:1-8, which lists 28 times or seasons. In Kabbalah, these are associated with cycles of divine influence through Binah (Understanding).

אחותה[i] ובכל יד חמש אצבעות וימין יו״ד ה״א שמאל וא״ו ה״א. ויד ימין ושמאל הם י״ד אותיות שהם ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ וי״ד אחרים תמורתן כנודע שבהם מעוררים כח החסד העליון. והמבין טעם סמיכת כהן גדול על האברים הנקרבים על גבי המזבח יבין טעם שימת היד על המת או על קברו. וכיון דאתא לידן פסוק ויברכם ביום ההוא לא אמנע עצמי מלכתוב פרפרת אחד שיש לי בו [ii]

from it spread twenty-eight camps of the supernal moon. And by its power, there appear in the lower moon fourteen on the right and fourteen on the left, and they are two hands joined, one to the other, and in each hand five fingers, and the right [corresponds to] Yod-Hei and the left [to] Vav-Hei. And the right and left hands are fourteen letters which are "Hashem Eloheinu Hashem" and fourteen others in their place, as is known, through which the power of supernal Chesed is awakened. And one who understands the reason for the High Priest's laying hands on the limbs offered on the altar will understand the reason for placing the hand on the deceased or on his grave. And since the verse "And he blessed them on that day" [Genesis 48:20] has come to our hands, I will not withhold myself from writing one delightful insight that I have about it.

והוא כי יעקב בירך אפרים ומנשה שכל ישראל יתברכו בהם ויאמרו ישימך אלהים כאפרים וכמנשה ולא ראינו שנתקיימה ברכה זו באדם שמברך בנו או תלמידו. אך כשנעמוד על דעתנו נראה שלא נפל דבר מדברי יעקב ארצה. הנה הילדים הנולדים אחר מעט ימים תחלת דבורם הוא יאכ״ו[iii] וגם שהנשים הקלות מרגילות לומר

And it is that Jacob blessed Ephraim and Manasseh, that all Israel would be blessed through them, and they would say, "May God make you like Ephraim and like Manasseh." Yet we have not seen this blessing fulfilled when a person blesses his son or student. But when we consider this carefully, we see that none of Jacob's words have fallen to the ground. Behold, newborn children, after a few days, begin speaking with the sounds "YAKH'U,"[1] and even though simple women habitually say that afterward the infant said this on his own, it was actually the wise nat-

[1]The author is making a remarkable claim that infants' first sounds form an acronym for "ישימני אלהים באפרים ובמנשה" (May God make me like Ephraim and Manasseh), suggesting that children unconsciously fulfill Jacob's blessing formula.

[i]This beautiful metaphorical description of interlocked hands reflects the interconnected nature of the divine emanations in kabbalistic thought, where the right and left sides (representing mercy and judgment) work in harmony.

[ii]Cf. Isaiah 11:2-3 — The author uses these verses to discuss the spiritual perception that transcends ordinary senses, connecting them to the concept of 'garments of light' that represent higher spiritual perception. | Cf. Exodus 33:18-23 — The author interprets Moses' experience as gaining a partial spiritual perception (seeing God's 'back') because he still had some mixture of 'garments of skin' (physical limitation) despite his elevated spiritual state. | Cf. Isaiah 26:19 — The author relates this verse to the custom of placing hands on a coffin or grave, explaining that the fifteen words in this verse correspond to the fifteen joints in the human hand, creating a mystical connection to mercy for the deceased. | Cf. Numbers 14:17 — The verse is connected to the kabbalistic concept that the fourteen joints in the hand correspond to divine power flowing from Binah to Malkhut, with twenty-eight (twice fourteen) being a significant number in this mystical system. | Cf. Zohar — The author's exposition about the hands representing divine names and sefirot reflects Zoharic interpretations of the human body as a microcosm of divine structures.

[iii]This is a unique transliteration representing the sounds supposedly made by infants that the author interprets mystically as an acronym for 'ישימני אלהים באפרים ובמנשה' (May God make me like Ephraim and Manasseh).

אח״ז התנוק מעצמו היה אומר
יאכ״ו והטבע החכם הרגיל
אותו לומר כך שהוא מברך את
עצמו ואומר "ישימני "אלהים
"כאפרים "וכמנשה. או "ישימכם
"אלהים "כאפרים "וכמנשה והוא
מברך אביו ואמו שהולידוהו.
וזה להיות כי העולם נברא
בלשון הקדש ובח מוצא כל
הנבראים הם מרוחניות העולם
ונכלל באותיות התורה שהם
כ״ב חפצים וגוף אחד. וזו היתה
חכמתו של אדם הראשון בקריאת
שמות שידוע שרוחניות הנכלל
בשי״ן ומ״ם פתוחה וביו״ד
ובמ״ם סתומה ובכחם ורוחניותם
ברא הבורא שמים. וכן ארץ
בא׳ ור׳ וצ׳. וכן שור בש״ן
וא״ו רי״ש. וכן על זה הדרך
בכל הנבראים כנתבאר בתקון
נ״ח בדרוש משמות הרבה אשר
למטטרון שאמר כי נקרא בששים
רבוא שמות של מלאכים[i] ובתקון
ששים אמר למה מטטרון נקרא
מטה ולמה משה נשתמש במטה לא
כן שאר נביאים ועיין בתקון ס״ח
מזה ושמטטרון מתהפך לארבע
פנים וכללות צורת אדם מכל מה
שנברא בשמים ובארץ ולהיות
שכל העולם נברא ברוחניות
התורה[ii] מזה הוכיח ר׳ שמעון
בן יוחאי בפרשת תרומה דף
קס״א שהמשתדל בתורה כ״י
הוא מקיים העולם דאמר קב״ה
אסתכל בתורה וברא עלמא. צא
ולמד כח אותיות התורה ידוע כי
צורת הנשמה מחוברת מאותיות
הקדש כסדרי המצות אלו יעשה

ural order that trained him to say this,[1] for he is blessing himself, saying: "May God make me like Ephraim and Manasseh." Or "May God make you [plural] like Ephraim and Manasseh," thereby blessing his father and mother who gave birth to him. This is because the world was created in the holy tongue,[2] and the power in the utterance of all created things comes from the spiritual essence of the world, which is contained in the letters of the Torah, which are twenty-two entities forming a single body. This was the wisdom of Adam in naming all creatures, for it is known that the spiritual essence contained in the letters shin and open mem and in yod and closed mem, and through their power and spiritual nature, the Creator made heaven (shamayim). And similarly earth (eretz) with alef, resh, and tzadi. And ox (shor) with shin, vav, and resh. And so forth with all created things, as explained in Tikkun 58 in the discourse on the many names of Metatron, where it says that he is called by six hundred thousand names of angels. And in Tikkun 60 it asks why Metatron is called a staff and why Moses used a staff when other prophets did not. See also Tikkun 68 about this, and how Metatron transforms into four faces and encompasses the complete human form from everything created in heaven and earth. And since the entire world was created through the spiritual essence of the Torah, Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai proved from this in Parashat Terumah, page 161, that one who engages in Torah study sustains the world, for the Holy One, blessed be He, said, "I looked into the Torah and created the world." Go and learn the power of the letters of the Torah. It is known that the form of the soul is composed of holy letters arranged according to the commandments:[3] "which if a person does, he shall live by them"—literally—for life and peace will accompany his soul in the supernal realms, and from there will reach his physical body

[1] The author reinterprets what appears to be random infant babbling as divinely orchestrated speech with deep spiritual significance.
[2] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that Hebrew is not merely a conventional language but the actual medium through which God created reality, with each letter containing creative power.
[3] This presents a striking spiritual anatomy where the soul itself is structured from Hebrew letters, with commandment observance maintaining their proper arrangement and sin disrupting it.

[i] The concept that Metatron has 600,000 angelic names corresponds to the traditional number of Israelites who left Egypt, suggesting a correspondence between human and angelic realms.
[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic principle that the Torah served as the blueprint for creation, with Hebrew letters containing the spiritual essence that formed physical reality.

אותם האדם וחי בהם ממש כי
יתלוו אליו החיים והשלום על
נשמתו בעליונים וממנו יגיע אל
האדם הגופני חיים וחסד ויתחזק
כל אבר מאברי הנשמה בכח רוח
אלהים חיים ואם יעבור אדם על
המצות אז ישתנו סדרי האותיות
אשר בנשמתו ויכתבו לעבירה
שעשה שנאמר ותהי עונותם על
עצמותם חקוקים[i] והנה הוא בכף
חובה וה׳ בעל החיים סר מעליו
והאבר ההוא אם הנשמה תלויה
בו מיד מת או נכרת ואם אין
הנשמה תלויה בו הוא חולה או
נפסד בסוד והפקדתי עליכם
בהלה וכו׳. ונחזור לדרושנו
שלהיות כי הטביע הטבע מלה
דו בפי התינוקות כנדרש גם
הילדים שאינם מבני עמנו תחלת
דבורם יאכ״ו כנזכר וכבר נודע
ממעשה אשר אירע כי ילד אשר
לא ישמע לדבר בשום לשון
תחלת דבורו יהיה בלשון הקדש
כי בעל הטבע שהוא אלהים
בגימטריא טבע.[ii] הטביע כן
בעולמו בסוד אותיות תורתו
שבה נסתכל וברא העולם. וסמך
על מה שמשימים החומש לילדים
מראשותיהם הוא מפסוק זה ספר
תולדות אדם שביום שקורין
לו שם משימין ס׳ תורת כהנים
מראשותיו ובשמגיע ללמוד
שהוא כבן חמש שנים מתחילים
לו בספר ויקרא[iii] שהעולם
מתקיים בהבלם כמו בזכות

with life and kindness, and each limb of his soul will be strengthened by the power of the spirit of the living God. But if a person transgresses the commandments, then the arrangement of letters in his soul will be altered[1] and will be inscribed with the sin he committed, as it is said, "Their iniquities are engraved upon their bones." Then he is on the side of guilt, and the Lord of Life departs from him. If the soul depends on that limb, it immediately dies[2] or is cut off, and if the soul does not depend on it, it becomes sick or damaged, in the mystery of "I will appoint over you terror," etc. Let us return to our discourse: since nature has implanted this word in the mouths of infants, as we have explained, even children who are not of our people begin speaking with "YAKH'U" as mentioned. It is already known from a case that occurred that a child who does not hear any language will begin speaking in the holy tongue, because the Master of Nature, which is Elohim (numerically equivalent to "nature"), has implanted this in His world through the mystery of the letters of His Torah, through which He looked and created the world. And this is supported by the custom of placing a Chumash at the head of children, based on the verse "This is the book of the generations of Adam," for on the day they name him, they place the book of Torat Kohanim at his head. And when he begins to study at about five years old, they begin with the book of Leviticus, for the world is sustained by their breath[3] just as by the merit of the sacrifices. "Do not touch My anointed ones" refers to the conversations of children. Also, their beginning with Leviticus helps with their purification after they emerge from the years of orlah (the first three years when a tree's fruit is forbidden). There is support for

[1] This suggests that sin physically reconfigures one's spiritual structure, not just metaphorically but literally changing the composition of the soul.

[2] The author proposes a direct connection between specific limbs, soul components, and commandments, suggesting that certain sins can cause immediate spiritual or physical death to corresponding body parts.

[3] This refers to the rabbinic teaching that the world is sustained by the breath of children studying Torah, which has special purity and power. The comparison to sacrifices suggests their breath serves as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings.

[i] This is a striking image where sin physically inscribes itself on a person's spiritual and physical being, altering their essential structure.

[ii] The Hebrew word for God (אלהים) has the same numerical value (86) as the word for nature (טבע), suggesting that nature itself is divine in origin.

[iii] The traditional Jewish educational practice of beginning children's Torah study with Leviticus rather than Genesis is here given a mystical justification.

הקרבנות. אל תגעו במשיחי
ירצה בשיחת התינוקות[i] ועוד
התחלתם בספר ויקרא מועיל
לטהרתם אחר שיצאו משני ערלה
ויש סמך לזה במדרש רבה.
ואמרו כי מן השמים עוזרים
לקטן וכן כתוב שומר פתאים
ה׳ ולא ינום ולא יישן שומר
ישראל:[ii]

this in Midrash Rabbah. And they said that heaven helps the young child, as it is written, "The Lord preserves the simple," and "The guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps." 200R

פרק מ״ד

Chapter 44

הרבה כוונות מצינו בס׳ הזהר
בפסוק שמע ישראל[iii] ובתקונים
ובמפרשים אשר לא יכילם ספר
ולהיות כי ידיעת כוונת יחוד זה
נוגע לשלמות מלאכתנו בחבור
הזה כאשר ישפוט כל מעיין
ע״כ שבתי וראה כי טוב הוא
להציע כוונה זו פה כפי דרכי
המקובלים ובפרט כאשר הורנו
המקובל קורדואי״רו זצ״ל[iv] וגם

We find many intentions[1] (kavvanot) in the Zohar regarding the verse "Hear O Israel," as well as in the Tikkunim and commentaries, more than a book could contain.[2] Since understanding the intention of this unification is essential to the completion of our work in this composition, as any reader will judge, I have therefore returned and seen that it is good to present this intention here according to the ways of the Kabbalists, particularly as taught by the Kabbalist Cordovero, of blessed memory. Also, the disciples 5R 10R

[1]The Hebrew term 'kavvanot' refers specifically to mystical intentions or meditative focuses used during prayer in Kabbalah, particularly the mental visualizations and divine name concentrations.
[2]The author is emphasizing the vast breadth of kabbalistic interpretations of the Shema, suggesting that his selection represents only a portion of available teachings.

[i]The author creatively interprets Psalm 105:15, "Do not touch My anointed ones," as referring to children's speech, elevating children's babbling to a form of divine utterance.
[ii]Cf. Genesis 48:20 — Jacob's blessing of Ephraim and Manasseh, that all Israel would be blessed through them, is the starting point for this mystical exploration of children's first words. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 58 — The reference to the discourse on Metatron's many names connects to the kabbalistic understanding of the relationship between divine names, angels, and created reality. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 60 — The reference to why Metatron is called a staff and Moses used a staff connects to kabbalistic teachings about the channeling of divine power through physical objects. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 68 — The reference to Metatron transforming into four faces connects to kabbalistic teachings about the mystical correspondence between celestial and human forms. | Cf. Zohar, Terumah 161 — The citation of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's teaching that engaging in Torah study sustains the world because God looked into the Torah and created the world provides a foundational kabbalistic principle for the entire passage. | Cf. Leviticus 18:5 — The phrase "which if a person does, he shall live by them" is used to establish the idea that the commandments literally provide life and sustenance to the soul and body. | Cf. Ezekiel 32:27 — The reference to iniquities being engraved on bones provides a textual basis for the idea that sin physically alters the spiritual structure of a person. | Cf. Leviticus 26:16 — The phrase "I will appoint over you terror" is used to support the idea that sin leads to spiritual and physical ailments. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah — The reference to Midrash Rabbah supporting the practice of beginning children's Torah study with Leviticus connects this mystical practice to rabbinic tradition. | Cf. Psalms 121:4 — The quotation "The guardian of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps" is used to emphasize divine protection of young children in their developmental process.
[iii]The first verse of the Shema prayer (Deuteronomy 6:4), Judaism's central declaration of faith, which proclaims God's unity. In kabbalistic tradition, it holds profound importance as a means of unifying divine realms and is traditionally recited before death.
[iv]Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), one of the foremost Kabbalists of Safed, known for his

שגורי האר״י זצ״ל[i] דרשו בו
גם הם גימטריאות וצרופים
וכוונות נכבדות מאד. ונבחר
הדרך יותר מפורסם ופשוט
כפי רוב יודעי מדע שהוא
דרך הגאון הנזכר יעלוז על
משכבו בשלום. ובטרם נבא
אל המכוון אלינו בזה נציע פה
לשונות מרעיא מהימנא ומהזהר
והתקונים להלהיב המכוין והוא
מן הדרושים אשר יאותו לקרות
אותם בפני המוטל על ערש
דוי[ii] וזהמתו חיתו לחם וכ״ש אם
ח״ו תקרב חייתו לממיתים כי
בהרבה פרקים אשר באו בשלשה
חלקי ספר זה פדה נפשו מעבור
בשלח הלא היא חרב מלאך המות
כי מלאך אכזרי לא ישולח בו
בהפרדו וחיתו באור תראה כי
ישוב מדרכו הרעה ויכין לבו
לדרוש את ה׳ ויקנה דבקות
במלכו[iii] וימסור נפשו על יחוד
שמו בקרבן שי ומנחה וישכב

of the ARI, of blessed memory, have expounded on it using gematrias, letter combinations,[1] and very significant intentions. We will choose the more well-known and straightforward approach[2] according to most knowledgeable scholars, which is the approach of the aforementioned Gaon—may he rejoice on his resting place in peace. 15R

Before we proceed to our intended purpose, we will present here passages from Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd), the Zohar, and the Tikkunim to inspire the one who meditates. These belong to the discourses which are suitable to read before one who lies on his sickbed and whose life-force consumes bread,[3] and especially if, God forbid, his life approaches those who cause death. For in many chapters that appear in the three parts of this book, he has redeemed his soul from passing through the sword—which is the sword of the Angel of Death[4]—so that a cruel angel will not be sent against him when he departs, and his soul will see light when he turns from his evil way and prepares his heart to seek the Lord. He will acquire attachment to his King and surrender his soul for 20R 25R 30R

[1] These represent specific kabbalistic techniques where Hebrew letters are assigned numerical values (gematria) or rearranged in different permutations (tzerufim) to reveal hidden meanings.
[2] The author is making a conscious choice to follow Cordovero's more systematic approach rather than the more complex Lurianic system, reflecting a concern for accessibility.
[3] This is a metaphorical expression referring to someone who is still able to eat but is gravely ill. The Hebrew uses poetic language to describe different stages of illness.
[4] In Jewish mystical tradition, the Angel of Death is described as wielding a sword from which drops of gall cause death. The proper meditation is presented as protection against this.

systematic approach to Kabbalah in works like 'Pardes Rimmonim.' The author expresses a preference for his more systematic and accessible approach.
[i] Rabbi Isaac Luria (1534-1572), known as the ARI, who revolutionized Kabbalah with his complex system of cosmic creation, breaking of vessels, and soul reincarnation. His disciples continued his work after his death.
[ii] The text indicates that these kabbalistic meditations are intended to be read to those who are gravely ill or dying, establishing a practical application for this mystical knowledge.
[iii] Devekut (mystical attachment to God) is presented as a spiritual achievement that protects the soul during its transition at death, showing how mystical practice has practical consequences for the afterlife journey.

ויערב לו שנתו. [i]

the unification of His Name,[1] like an offering and a gift, and he will lie down and his sleep will be sweet to him. 35R

כתוב ברעיא מהימנא סוף פ׳ בא אל פרעה וחמה גוונין דיחודא אתערו וכלהו קשוט מאן דעביד האי עביד. ומאן דעביד האי עביד. ויהיה זה לפי מחצב הנשמות[ii] שלאחת יאות יחוד זה. ולאחרת האחר. ואמרי׳ בפ׳ בשלח דף נ״ז ע״א כל בר נש דאתי ליחדא שמא קדישא ולא אתכוון ביה בלבא ורעותא ודחילו בגין דיתברכון ביה עילאי ותתאי רמאן ליה צלותיה לבר[iii] וכלהו מכרזי עליה לביש וקב״ה קרי ביה כי תבאו לראות פני כי תבאו לראות מבעי ליה מאי לראות אלא כל אינון אנפין דמלכא טמירין בעמקא לאתר חשוכא וכל אינון דידעין ליחדא שמא קדישא כדקא יאות מבקעין כל אינון כותלי חשוכא[iv] ואנפין דמלכא

It is written in Ra'aya Mehemna at the end of the section "Come to Pharaoh" that these are the colors of unification[2] that are aroused, and all of them are true—one who performs this, performs [correctly], and one who performs that, performs [correctly]. This will be according to the soul-root,[3] for one soul this unification is appropriate, and for another, the other [unification]. And we say in Parashat Beshalach, page 57a: "Any person who comes to unify the holy Name but does not concentrate with his heart, desire, and reverence, so that the upper and lower realms[4] may be blessed through it—his prayer is cast outside, and all [the angels] proclaim about him negatively. The Holy One, blessed be He, applies to him the verse 'when you come to appear before Me'—it should have said 'when you come to see,' why does it say 'to appear'? Because all those faces of the King are hidden in the depths, in a place of darkness, and all those who know how to unify the holy Name properly break through all those walls of darkness,[5] and the faces of the King appear 40R 45R 50R 55R

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of martyrdom or self-sacrifice through deep meditation on divine unity, which is considered spiritually equivalent to physical martyrdom.

[2] The term 'gavanim d'yichuda' (colors of unification) refers to different modes or aspects of divine unification in Kabbalistic practice, suggesting that unification has multiple dimensions or qualities.

[3] In Kabbalah, each soul has a specific 'root' or source in the divine structure, which determines its spiritual nature and appropriate devotional practices.

[4] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that reality consists of higher spiritual worlds and lower material worlds, all of which are affected by human religious practice.

[5] This metaphor describes how proper kavvanah (intention) during prayer penetrates spiritual barriers that normally separate humans from direct divine experience.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author is drawing on the Zohar's teachings about the mystical significance of the Shema as a powerful unification practice, especially important at the time of death. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author references this text as a source for specific mystical techniques and interpretations of the Shema. | Cf. Moses Cordovero's writings — The author specifically prefers Cordovero's approach to the Shema over other more complex interpretations, indicating his preference for systematic and accessible mystical practices. | Cf. ARI's (Isaac Luria's) teachings — The author acknowledges the ARI's approach while indicating a preference for Cordovero's method, suggesting a conscious choice between different kabbalistic systems. | Cf. Shema Yisrael prayer — The author is discussing the mystical intentions for this prayer, which is traditionally recited as one's final words before death, making it especially relevant to the book's focus on deathbed practices.

[ii] The text establishes that different souls require different methods of unification, suggesting a kabbalistic understanding that souls originate from different spiritual sources and thus may need different techniques for connecting with the divine.

[iii] The Zohar emphasizes here that prayer without proper intention is not merely ineffective but actively rejected, 'cast outside' the divine realms.

[iv] This powerful metaphor describes how proper unification breaks through 'walls of darkness' that obscure divine presence, suggesting that mystical practice can penetrate cosmic barriers.

אתחזיין ונהירין לכלא. וכד
אינון אתחזיק ונהרין מתברכין
כלא עלאין ותתאין. כדין ברכאן
אשתכחו בכלהו עלמין וכדין
כתיב לראות פני וגו׳ ובסוף
כתב ואי איהו אתי. ליחדא
שמא קדישא ולא אתכוין ביה
ברעותא דלבא בדחילו קב״ה
אמר מי בקש זאת מידכם רמוס
חצרי[i] דמשרין דינין במדת זאת
בההיא דכתיב בזאת יבא אהרן
אל הקדש וממנה מתפשט הדין
בכלא חס ושלום. וזהו תמצית
המורם מר״מ פרשת ואתחנן כי
נראה לנו יחוד נאות והגון לכוין
בו בשעת יציאת נשמה[ii] שמע
ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד. כמה
דמיחדי שמא דקודשא בריך
הוא לתתא הכי אתייחד לעילא
מיד אשתכח קודשא ברוך הוא
יחידא לעילא ותתא מאן דמיחד
שמיה דקודשא בריך הוא ישוי
לביה ורעותיה בההוא יחודא
דקאמרן ויחבר כל שייפוהי
בההוא יחודא למהוי כלא חד
כמא דשוי כל שייפוהי ברזא דחד
הכי לעילא מחבר כל שייפין
עילאין בההוא יחודא למהוי
כלא חד. בשעתא דאתי ליחדא
שמיה דקודשא בריך הוא כל
חילי שמיא כולהו קיימין שורין
שורין בגין לאתתקנא ולאתכללא
כולהו בההוא יחודא למיקם
ברזא דחד ביחודא חדא כולהו
מתתקנן בתקוניהון בההיא שעתא
קיימא חד שמשא דלקיט שושנים
דאינון שייפין עילאין ברזא
דמ״ב שמהן ואתלקיטו כולהו

and shine to all. And when they appear and shine, all are blessed—both the upper and lower realms. Then blessings are found in all worlds, and thus it is written ‘to appear before Me,’ etc.” And at the end it is written: “And if one comes to unify the holy Name but does not concentrate with the desire of his heart in reverence, the Holy One, blessed be He, says: ‘Who has required this from your hand, to trample My courts?’—for they cause judgments in the attribute of ‘this’ (zot),[1] which is referenced in ‘with this shall Aaron come into the sanctuary,’ and from it judgment spreads to all, God forbid. 60R 65R

This is the essential extract from Ra’aya Mehemna, Parashat Va’etchanan, for it seems to us that an appropriate and fitting unification to concentrate on at the time of the soul’s departure is “Hear, O Israel, the LORD our God, the LORD is One.” Just as they unify the name of the Holy One, blessed be He, below, so is He unified above. Immediately, the Holy One, blessed be He, is found unified above and below. One who unifies the name of the Holy One, blessed be He, should direct his heart and will to that unification we mentioned, and connect all his limbs in that unification[2] so that all becomes one. Just as he makes all his limbs function in the mystery of oneness, so above, all the supernal limbs are connected in that unification to become all one. 70R 75R 80R 85R

In the hour when one comes to unify the name of the Holy One, blessed be He, all the heavenly hosts stand in rows upon rows in order to be established and included in that unification, to stand in the mystery of oneness in a single unity. They are all arranged in their proper order. At that moment, there stands an attendant who gathers roses,[3] which are the supernal limbs, in the mystery of the 42 divine names. They are all gathered in that unification and made into a single body in a single mystery. Then all 90R 95R

[1] In Kabbalah, ‘zot’ often refers to the Shekhinah or divine feminine presence, associated with the sefirah of Malkhut, which can be a channel for either blessing or judgment.
[2] The concept of ‘limbs’ here refers both to the physical body of the worshipper and to cosmic ‘limbs’ or attributes of divinity that are unified through proper prayer.
[3] This refers to the angel Metatron or a similar celestial being who collects the spiritual effects of proper unification and arranges them into a unified divine structure.

[i] The text uses this harsh prophetic rebuke to emphasize that improper unification is not merely neutral but actively harmful, causing the spread of judgment rather than blessing.
[ii] This establishes the specific purpose of this teaching: to provide the optimal unification practice for the moment of death, which in Jewish mystical tradition is considered a spiritually critical transition.

בההוא וחודא ואתעבידו כולהו
95 גופא חדא ברזא חדא ואז כולהו
שיפין מתחברן בחבורא חדא
עילא ותתא ברזא דה׳ אחד ושמו
אחד ולכן אמרו דמאריכין באחד
כמלקט שושנים[i] לאתייחדא י״ב
100 אחד ביחודא שלים. ובדין יקרא
כלא קרבן שלים ועל רזא דא
אעיל ליה קודשא בריך הוא
בג״ע לאדם קדמאה דכתיב
לעבדה ולשמרה ותנינן דאלין
105 אינון קרבנין תרין רזא דה׳ אחד
ושמו אחד בדין מתעטר קודשא
בריך הוא בעטרת ברישא דכתם
פז. בהאי שושנים אית ביה שית
מאה ותליסר פקודין[ii] דאינון
110 שיפין מתרין סטרין ברזא דה׳
אחד ושמו אחד. ותפוח מעצי
היער ושושנים מבין החוחים דא
ודא אצטריך לאסתכלא כחדא
ביחודא שלים זכאה איהו מאן
115 דקריב קרבנין אלין ודאי לרעות
ליה בהאי עלמא ובעלמא דאתי
וכתוב בפקודין בפרשת משפטים
דף קי״ט דמאן דמיחד לקב״ה
בכל יומא בעי דליהוי מיתתיה
120 [iii] באחד

the limbs connect in a single connection, above and below, in the mystery of "The LORD is One and His name is One." Therefore, they said that one should extend [the pronunciation of] "echad" (one) like one who gathers roses,[1] to unify the twelve [tribes of Israel represented by] "echad" in complete unification. Then all is considered a complete offering. 100R

Based on this mystery, the Holy One, blessed be He, placed Adam, the first man, in the Garden of Eden, as it is written "to work it and to guard it."[2] And we have learned that these are two offerings [corresponding to] the mystery of "The LORD is One and His name is One." Then the Holy One, blessed be He, is crowned with a crown on His head of fine gold. In these roses there are six hundred and thirteen commandments,[3] which are limbs from two sides, in the mystery of "The LORD is One and His name is One." "An apple tree among the trees of the forest" and "lilies among the thorns"—both of these need to be contemplated together in complete unification. Fortunate is one who offers these sacrifices to please Him in this world and in the World to Come. 105R 110R 115R

And it is written in the Commandments section in Parashat Mishpatim, page 119, that one who unifies the Holy One, blessed be He, every day should have his death with [the word] "echad"[4] (one). 120R

[1] This describes the traditional practice of prolonging the pronunciation of the word 'echad' (one) in the Shema, visualizing the gathering of divine attributes into unity.

[2] The text interprets Adam's duty in Eden as performing two types of offerings or unifications, connecting physical action with cosmic maintenance.

[3] The 613 mitzvot (commandments) are mystically understood as corresponding to parts of the divine and human structure, with their observance creating cosmic wholeness.

[4] This refers to the tradition of dying while reciting the Shema, specifically with 'echad' (one) as the final word, considered an ideal death in Jewish tradition.

[i] This refers to the practice of prolonging the word 'echad' (one) in the Shema, comparing it to gathering roses—a metaphor for collecting and unifying the divine sparks or attributes.

[ii] The 613 commandments are mystically understood as corresponding to limbs or organs of the divine and human body, suggesting that proper observance of mitzvot creates cosmic wholeness.

[iii] Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — This text from Ra'aya Mehemna, a mystical commentary within the Zohar, discusses proper kavvanah (intention) during prayer, explaining that different souls may require different unification techniques. | Cf. Zohar, Beshalach — This section emphasizes the importance of proper intention when unifying God's name, warning that prayers without proper concentration are rejected while those with proper intention break through cosmic barriers. | Cf. Shema Yisrael — The Shema prayer is identified as the ideal unification to recite at the moment of death, with the extended pronunciation of 'echad' (one) being particularly significant. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Mishpatim — This reference connects daily practice of divine unification with one's final moments, suggesting that those who properly unify God's name daily will merit doing so at death. | Cf. Genesis 2:15 — The text interprets Adam's duty to 'work and guard' the Garden of Eden as referring to performing two types of offerings/unifications corresponding to 'The LORD is One and His name is One.' | Cf. Zechariah 14:9 — This prophetic verse is interpreted as

כגוונא דשחיטת בהמה בתריסר
בדיקות דסכין[i] ובסכין דאיהו
אחד ומברך ומקדש לקב״ה בכל
יומא בברכו ובקדושה ובכל
125 אכילה ושתיה דיליה הנה כי
צריך למסור נפשו בעת אמירת
אחד[ii] כדכתיב כי עליך הורגנו
כל היום נחשבנו כצאן טבחה
שאנו צאנו של הקב״ה למקריב
130 גרמן קרבן לגביה ביחוד שמע
ישראל ובתעניות ג״כ וברוח
העולה כלול בתורה ובמצות
ובכל מצוה סליק שכינתא
לגבי קב״ה והאדם הזריז
135 בברכו וקדושה וברכת הנהנין
כדין קב״ה נחית על ההוא
רוחא בכמה משריין ואליהו
ודאי[iii] ובכמה משריין דמטרוניתא
סלקין עמיה ומשריין דמלכא
140 נחתין לגביה וכלהו לנטרא ליה
ולאודעא להההוא רוחא כמה רזין
דאורייתא וכ״ש אם יכוין באחד
בעת יציאת נשמתו שמלאכי
אלהים יפגעו בו בכוונו ליחוד
145 קב״ה ושכינתיה וכדין אבא
ואמא רחמין ליה[iv] ונשקין ליה
ואינון גופייהו נטרין ליה ויפוק

Just as with the slaughtering of an animal,[1] which requires twelve inspections of the knife and a knife that is "one" (perfectly smooth),[2] and as one blesses and sanctifies the Holy One, blessed be He, every 125R
day with the Barchu and Kedushah prayers and with every act of eating and drinking—so too must one surrender one's soul when saying "Echad" (One) in the Shema, as it is written: "For Your sake we are killed all day long; we are considered as sheep for 130R
the slaughter." For we are the flock of the Holy One, blessed be He, offering ourselves as sacrifices to Him through the unification of "Hear, O Israel," and likewise through fasts. And through the ascending spirit, which is included in Torah and command- 135R
ments, the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) ascends to the Holy One, blessed be He, with every commandment performed. When one is diligent in reciting Barchu, Kedushah, and blessings over enjoyments, the Holy One, blessed be He, descends upon that 140R
spirit with many heavenly hosts—certainly Elijah as well—and many hosts of the Divine Queen (Matronita) ascend with him, while the hosts of the King descend to him. All come to protect him and to make known to that spirit many secrets of the Torah. 145R
How much more so if one concentrates on "Echad" (One) at the time of the soul's departure—angels of God will meet him as he directs his intention toward

[1]The text creates a striking parallel between ritual animal slaughter and the spiritual self-sacrifice required during prayer, particularly when reciting the Shema. This comparison would have been immediately understood by the original audience familiar with the meticulous requirements of Jewish ritual slaughter.

[2]The term 'one' (אחד) for the knife creates a deliberate connection to the word 'One' in the Shema prayer, suggesting that just as the knife must be perfectly smooth to be 'one,' so must the worshipper's consciousness be undivided when declaring God's unity.

describing the cosmic effect of proper unification, where all divine limbs connect in unity above and below. | Cf. Song of Songs 2:3 — The text uses this verse alongside 'lilies among thorns' as metaphors requiring contemplation to achieve complete unification, suggesting these represent different aspects of divinity. | Cf. Isaiah 1:12 — This prophetic rebuke is applied to those who recite unifications without proper intention, suggesting that improper prayer not only fails but actually causes harm by spreading judgment.

[i]This refers to the twelve inspections required for a ritual slaughter knife to ensure its perfect smoothness. The author uses this halakhic requirement as a metaphor for the precision and care needed in spiritual preparation.

[ii]The kabbalistic practice of surrendering one's soul during the recitation of the word 'Echad' (One) in the Shema prayer is a central mystical practice. This moment of declaring God's unity is seen as a daily opportunity for spiritual death and rebirth.

[iii]The prophet Elijah is believed in Jewish mysticism to attend moments of spiritual elevation, particularly serving as a guide for souls ascending to higher realms.

[iv]'Father and Mother' (Abba ve-Imma) in Kabbalistic terminology refer to the divine partzufim (configurations) corresponding to the sefirot of Chokhmah (Wisdom) and Binah (Understanding), which together generate the lower divine attributes.

נשמתיה בנשיקא[i] דאיהי דבקותא
דרוחא ברוחא דלא מתפרש
מיניה ודא אקרי נשיקה דאיהי
בפה דבקותא דרוחא ברוחא
עלאה [ii]

the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence. Then the Father and Mother (supernal divine aspects)[1] will have compassion on him and kiss him, and they themselves will protect him. His soul will depart with a kiss,[2] which is the cleaving of spirit to spirit, never to be separated from Him. This is called "the kiss," which is, through the mouth, the cleaving of spirit to supernal spirit.

ועיין מכוונת היחוד בפ׳ תרומה
דף קל״ג. איך מתפרשת ב״י
מסטרא אחרא ובזה עולה לחופה
עם בעלה.[iii] עוד שם בדף קנ״ט
ביאר שמות המרגלא שהם אל
מימין אלהים משמאל אלהינו
באמצע[iv] ומפתח דכולא ידו״ד
שדי צבאות אבגית״ץ וכו׳ ע״ש.
ובר״מ פ׳ יתרו דף צ״ב ובדף

See also regarding the intentions of unification in Parashat Terumah, page 133, which explains how the Community of Israel separates from the Other Side and thereby ascends to the wedding canopy with her husband.[3] Also there on page 159, he explains the names of the formula, which are: El on the right, Elohim on the left, Eloheinu in the center, and the key to all is YHVH, Shaddai, Tzeva'ot, ABGITATZ,[4] etc.—see there. And in

[1] I've added a parenthetical explanation that these terms refer to divine aspects, as the original text assumes familiarity with kabbalistic terminology where 'Father and Mother' (Abba ve-Imma) refer to the divine configurations of Chokhmah and Binah.

[2] The concept of 'death by divine kiss' (mittat neshikah) is a significant mystical idea that represents the most elevated form of death. Unlike ordinary death through the Angel of Death, death by divine kiss is painless and represents direct communion with the divine.

[3] The original uses marriage metaphors to describe the mystical union of divine entities. The 'wedding canopy' (chuppah) represents the state of complete unification between the feminine divine presence (Shekhinah) and the masculine aspect of divinity.

[4] These are divine names used in kabbalistic meditation. ABGITATZ is the first word formed from the initial letters of the 42-letter divine name, which has special significance in Jewish mysticism, particularly for deathbed practices.

[i] Death by divine kiss (mittat neshikah) is considered in Jewish tradition to be the most elevated form of death, reserved for the most righteous. Moses, Aaron, and Miriam are traditionally believed to have died in this manner—their souls departing through a painless divine kiss rather than through the Angel of Death.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — This passage draws heavily on Zoharic concepts of divine unification through prayer, especially the idea that reciting the Shema with proper intention creates cosmic unifications between divine attributes. The Zohar frequently describes this process using imagery of marriage between the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity. | Cf. Psalms 44:23 — The author uses this verse to support the idea that reciting the Shema with full concentration, especially the word 'Echad' (One), requires a willingness to surrender one's soul to God, metaphorically dying in the process of declaring divine unity. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This passage reflects the Tikkunei Zohar's emphasis on how specific human actions (prayer, blessings, etc.) cause corresponding movements in the divine realms, with angels and divine hosts responding to human spiritual initiatives. | Cf. Song of Songs — The passage's discussion of the 'kiss' as spiritual union draws on the Song of Songs' imagery as interpreted in Kabbalistic literature, where divine kiss represents the highest form of spiritual union and, when occurring at death, the most elevated form of departure from this world.

[iii] This phrase uses marriage imagery to describe the mystical union between the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) and the Holy One, blessed be He. The 'wedding canopy' (chuppah) represents the state of complete unification.

[iv] This represents the kabbalistic arrangement of divine names corresponding to the right side (mercy), left side (judgment), and the central column (balance), reflecting the structure of the sefirot (divine emanations).

ק״ס וקס״א פירוש סוד היחוד
ה׳ הוא האלהים[i] כלל גדול
ביחוד. ויש פירוש אחר ביחוד
פ׳ ויקהל דף רט״ז ואמר דאליהו
ז״ל אוליף אותו יחוד ושהיה
יחודו של רב המנונא סבא שים
עיניך בתקון כ״ב דף ס״ג וס״ד
המתחיל קם ר״ש ואמר וכו׳
ומסיים מיני לעלם ותראה איך
נכללים כל הנבראים ונוצרים
ונעשים בשכינה ובחינת האברים
הרוחניים המכוונים באצילות
הם בסוד לבושיה לבד[ii] ותבין
סוד השגחה מהמיחד הכל ית״ש
לעד. עיין בציוני פ׳ ואתחנן
דף צ״ג ע״ב בפי׳ פסוק שמע
ישראל ותראה פלאות שספר
משה לישראל מסדר שרי מעלה
שראה בעלותו למרום וג׳ כוונות
[iv iii]בפסוק שמע ישראל:

Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Yitro, page 92, and on pages 160-161, there is an explanation of the secret of the unification "The LORD, He is God"[1]—a great principle in unification. There is another explanation of unification in Parashat Vayakhel, page 216, where it states that Elijah, of blessed memory, taught that unification, and that it was the unification method of Rav Hamnuna Saba. Set your eyes on Tikkun 22, pages 63-64, which begins "Rabbi Shimon arose and said..." and concludes "from me forever," and you will see how all created beings are included, formed, and made within the Shekhinah, and how the aspects of spiritual limbs that correspond to Atzilut[2] are merely in the secret of His garments. You will understand the secret of providence from the One who unifies everything, may He be blessed forever. Look in Tziyoni on Parashat Va'etchanan, page 93b, in the explanation of the verse "Hear, O Israel," and you will see wonders that Moses told Israel about the order of celestial princes that he saw during his ascent to heaven, and the three intentions in the verse "Hear, O Israel."[3]

[1]This phrase (Adonai Hu HaElohim) comes from 1 Kings 18:39 and represents the unification of divine attributes of mercy (YHVH) and judgment (Elohim), a fundamental concept in kabbalistic theology.

[2]This refers to the kabbalistic concept that divine structures in the highest world (Atzilut) serve as 'garments' or vehicles for divine manifestation rather than being the divine essence itself.

[3]The Shema prayer has special significance in deathbed practices as described elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok. These three kavvanot (mystical intentions) would be particularly important for someone reciting the Shema at the time of death.

[i]This biblical phrase ('The LORD, He is God') represents the ultimate unification of the divine attributes of mercy (YHVH) and judgment (Elohim), a central concept in kabbalistic theology.

[ii]This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the spiritual 'limbs' or structures in the highest world (Atzilut) are merely 'garments' or external manifestations of divine essence rather than the essence itself.

[iii]The text refers to three distinct mystical intentions (kavvanot) for the Shema prayer, which is particularly significant given that this passage appears in a section about deathbed practices, where the Shema has special importance.

[iv]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This section explains the mystical process by which the divine feminine aspect (Shekhinah) separates from impure forces in order to unite with the divine masculine aspect, a central theme in kabbalistic understanding of cosmic harmony. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna (section of the Zohar) — This section of the Zohar presents a fundamental principle about divine unification through the phrase 'The LORD, He is God,' which represents the harmonization of divine attributes of mercy (YHVH) and judgment (Elohim). | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — This text explores how all created beings are included within the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah), and how spiritual structures in the highest world (Atzilut) serve as 'garments' for divine manifestation. | Cf. Sefer HaTziyoni — This reference points to kabbalistic teachings about what Moses revealed concerning the angelic hierarchy he witnessed during his ascent to heaven, and suggests there are three distinct mystical intentions one should have when reciting the Shema prayer.

פרק מ״ה

Chapter 45

פירוש היחוד שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד לפי סדר היכלות היצירה בתפלת מיושב היחוד הוא בסוד היכל אהבה וד׳ פרשיות הם סוד אהבה פרשה ראשונה יש בה מ״ב תיבות ופ׳ שניה ע״ב ושלישית חמשים. ורביעית ע״ב הם סוד ד׳ היכלות עליונות שהם סוד מקוה שבה טובלת קומת הקדושה והוא סוד היות אורות אלו נפתחים ומטהרים הקדושה מכל פגם עון התחתונים. וההיכלות הם סוד דרום מצד החסד נפתחים מ״ב אורות ע״י מ״ב תיבות יושפע שפעם בחסד ובצפון ע״ב היכלות וע״י ע״ב תיבות שבפ׳ שניה נפתחים ע״ב אורות להאירה. ושם מ״ב הוא מפתח אורות מדרום ושם ע״ב מפתח אותם שבצפון לכן טוב. לכוין בכל תיבה מואהבת עד והיה אם שמוע אות אחת משם מ״ב בכל תיבה וכן בפ׳ שנייה יכוין שם אחד משם ע״ב בכל תיבה. והיה וה״ו וכן כלו ויכוין בשקורח פ׳ זו באותיותיה עם נקודותיה וטעמיה שיש לנפשו שהיא בסוד האותיות ורוחו שהוא בסוד הנקודות ולנשמתו שהיא בסוד הטעמים שכלם הם בראשו מרכבה ודבוק לשם של מ״ב ע״י מטטרו״ן שר הפנים הנרמז בפסוק ולקח הכהן

The explanation of the unification "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is One" according to the order of the Chambers of Formation in the seated prayer. The unification is in the mystery of the Chamber of Love,[1] and the four passages are the mystery of love. The first passage contains 42 words, the second 72, the third 50, and the fourth 72. These represent the mystery of the four supernal chambers which are the mystery of the ritual bath in which the divine structure immerses, and this is the secret of how these lights open and purify the holiness from all blemish of the sins of those below. 5R 10R

The chambers are the mystery of the south from the side of Loving-kindness (Chesed), where 42 lights open through the 42 words and their flow is influenced with kindness;[A] and in the north are 72 chambers, and through the 72 words in the second passage, 72 lights open to illuminate it. The 42-letter Name is the key to the lights from the south,[2] and the 72-letter Name is the key to those from the north, therefore it is good to focus on each word from "And you shall love" until "And it shall come to pass if you listen," associating one letter from the 42-letter Name with each word. Similarly, in the second passage, one should associate one name from the 72-letter Name with each word, beginning with "VaHaVu" and so on. 15R 20R 25R

When reciting this passage, one should focus on its letters, vowel points, and cantillation marks, which correspond to one's nefesh (vital soul) which is in the mystery of the letters, one's ruach (spirit) which is in the mystery of the vowel points, and one's neshamah (higher soul) which is in the mystery of the cantillation mark[3]s. All of these are in one's 30R

[A] Or: "The chambers represent the mystery of the south, associated with the divine attribute of Loving-kindness (Chesed), where 42 lights are opened through the 42 words, causing their divine flow to be infused with kindness" — This alternate translation more explicitly shows the causal relationship between reciting the words and the opening of spiritual channels, while also clarifying the theological concept that south corresponds to Chesed in kabbalistic cosmology.

[1] The term 'unification' (yichud) in Kabbalah refers to the mystical joining of different aspects of divinity, particularly the masculine and feminine divine attributes. The Shema prayer is considered the primary vehicle for this unification in daily prayer.

[2] The 42-letter divine name is not found explicitly in scripture but is derived from various sources including the first 42 letters of the creation story. It was considered extremely powerful in Jewish mysticism and used in meditative practices and protective amulets.

[3] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the Hebrew text itself contains multiple layers of meaning corresponding to different levels of soul and reality. The consonants (most fundamental), vowels

הטנא[i] ובקריאתו פרשה שניה יכוין ג״כ באותיות ונקודות וטעמים שיש לנפשו ורוחו ונשמתו אשר בגופו עם זרועותיו לשם ע״ב ע״י מטטרו״ן וזה כלל גדול בכל הכוונות ובזה מתקן קומתו כולה עם הקומה העליונה וכל אות תאיר ברמ״ח אבריו הרוחניים והגשמים כנר כדאמור במדרש. ועל זה הדרך בפ׳ שלישית ורביעית נפש רוח ונשמה אשר בשאר קומתו וכנזכר ובא שם מ״ב לימין ושם ע״ב לשמאל עם היות שם ע״ב חסד ושם מ״ב גבורה הגם שהוא גבוה מעל גבוה. בא כך כדי לכלול ימין בשמאל ושמאל בימין[ii] ולכן טוב בקריאת שמע לקשור יד ימין עם י״ד שמאל ולהגבירה. ובפ׳ ושמתם שהיא למזרח נפתחים חמשים אורות מצד הת״ת ואפשר ששמו יהיה נ״ד הויות שבאים מצרוף שם בן ד׳ ובפ׳ ציצית שהיא במערב נפתחים ע״ב מצד המלכות בעצמה ויש ע״ב שמות אחרים שמקורם ע״ב במלואו לזכר וע״ב הויות מקודם י׳ י״ה יה״ו יד״וד לנקבה וזה יהיה רמז הפרשיות שתים מע״ב תיבות ולעולם יכוין לכלול נפשו ורוחו ונשמתו עם שיפין עליונים הנכללים ביחוד קב״ה ושכינתיה ויכוין ברוחניות המצות הנצטווה בפרשיות אלו להאיר השכינה העליונה כי הם רבי הכמות והאיכות ועקר מחשבתו תהיה לעולם בסבת כל

head as a chariot and attachment to the 42-letter Name through Metatron, Prince of the Presence, who is alluded to in the verse "and the priest shall take the basket." When reading the second passage, one should also focus on the letters, vowel points, and cantillation marks that correspond to one's nefesh, ruach, and neshamah in one's body with its arms, connecting to the 72-letter Name through Metatron. This is a great principle for all mystical intentions, through which one rectifies one's entire structure along with the supernal structure, and each letter will illuminate one's 248 spiritual and physical limbs like a lamp, as stated in the Midrash.

Following this approach in the third and fourth passages, one connects the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah in the rest of one's structure as mentioned. The 42-letter Name comes to the right and the 72-letter Name to the left, even though the 72-letter Name is associated with Chesed (Kindness) and the 42-letter Name with Gevurah (Strength), despite the latter being higher than the former. This arrangement is to include right within left and left within right, and therefore it is good when reciting the Shema to bind the right hand with the left hand and to strengthen it.[1]

In the passage "And you shall place them," which corresponds to the east, 50 lights open from the side of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), and perhaps its name consists of 54 divine Names derived from permutations of the four-letter Name. In the passage about tzitzit (ritual fringes), which corresponds to the west, 72 lights open from the side of Malkhut (Kingdom) itself. There are 72 other names whose source is the fully spelled 72 for the masculine aspect, and 72 divine Names beginning with Yod, Yah, Yahu, YHVH for the feminine aspect. This alludes to the two passages each having 72 words.

(which animate the consonants), and cantillation marks (which give musical and interpretive structure) parallel the hierarchy of soul levels.

[1] This refers to a physical practice during the recitation of the Shema where one would clasp one's hands together, symbolizing the unification of different divine attributes (particularly judgment and mercy). This physical gesture was believed to facilitate the cosmic unifications being enacted through prayer.

[i] The text identifies a creative allusion to Metatron in the biblical verse 'and the priest shall take the basket' (Deuteronomy 26:4). This is likely based on gematria (numerical equivalence) or another form of kabbalistic word interpretation.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic principle of 'sweetening judgment with mercy' (המתקת הדינים), where the harsh aspects of divine judgment (left) are tempered by divine kindness (right), and mercy is given structure through judgment. This balance is considered essential for proper cosmic function.

הסבות המאציל ב״ה נשמה לכל
הנשמות ורצון כל הרצונות והוא
בעל הרצון מעולה מכל ברכה
ותהלה ובכחו הגדול מיחד כל
נאצליו ועקר התפלות והתחנות
אליו ולא למדותיו. ואם תרצה
לנוח קצת דעתך בזה היסוד
המוסד לכל שים עיניך בר״מ
פ׳ בא דף מ״ב מ״ג משם תראה
מהו מקור ומהו מעין ים ושבעה
נחלים וכלם מתאכלים מא״ס
בעל הרצון ושם פירוש מציאות
י׳ שמות שאינם נמחקים ופי׳
י׳ ספירות ואיך נכללים שבעה
נחלים במלכות ובה הגדולה
והגבורה והת״ת וכו׳ ואחר כך
פירוש משמשין לאילין דאינון
מאנין דכורסייא בארבע סמכין
ושית דרגין הא עשר ולבתר
פירוש עשר כתות המלאכים
לשמשא לכורסייא ולאלו שמשים
סמ״ך מ״ם וכתות דיליה דאינון
בעננין למרכב בהון לנחתא
לארעא ואינון כסוסין להון ואם
תבוין לבך ודעתך על חלום
שני של נ״נ שהיה בגזרת עירין
ובמימר קדישין ואמר גודו
אילנא וקציצו ענפוי ומן אינשא
נטרד ושבעה עידנין חלפו עליה
ועם חיות ברא הוה מדוריה
ותדע כי הוא היה רישא דדהבא
ראש קומת החצונים[i] בזה תבין
יחס חלום ראשון עם השני ואיך
קומת החצונים עתידה לבלות
על דרך ואת הצפוני ארחיק
מעליכם וגו׳ פתחתי פתח קטן
זה והחכם מדעתו יראה מעצמו
לכמה פנות מתרחב כי אין כאן
מקום דרוש זה. בפרטות פסוק
היחוד בו יש ששה תיבות יורה
כללותם שש ספירות שבת״ת

One should always intend to include one's nefesh, ruach, and neshamah with the supernal limbs that are included in the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence. One should 75R
focus on the spiritual dimension of the commandments instructed in these passages to illuminate the supernal Divine Presence, for they are many in quantity and quality. The core of one's thought should always be directed toward the Cause of all causes, the 80R
Emanator, blessed be He, who is the Soul of all souls and the Will of all wills. He is the Master of Will, exalted above all blessing and praise, and through His great power, He unifies all His emanations. The essence of prayers and supplications should be di- 85R
rected to Him, not to His attributes.

If you wish to rest your mind somewhat regarding this foundational principle, direct your attention to Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Bo, pages 42-43.[1] There you will see what is the source, what is the wellspring 90R
and sea, and the seven streams, all of which are sustained by the Infinite One (Ein Sof), the Master of Will. There is an explanation of the existence of the ten divine Names that may not be erased, an explanation of the ten sefirot, and how the seven streams 95R
are included in Malkhut, which contains "the greatness, the strength, the beauty," etc. Then there is an explanation of the attendants to these, which are the vessels of the Throne with four supports and six levels, making ten. Afterward, there is an explana- 100R
tion of the ten groups of angels serving the Throne, and to these attendants are Samekh Mem and his groups, which are like clouds for Him to ride upon to descend to earth, and they are like horses for them.

If you direct your heart and mind to Nebuchad- 105R
nezzar's second dream, which was by the decree of the watchers and the statement of the holy ones, saying, "Cut down the tree and chop off its branches, and from humanity he was driven away, and seven periods passed over him, and his dwelling was with 110R
the wild beasts," then you will know that he was the golden head, the head of the structure of the

[1] Ra'aya Mehemna ('The Faithful Shepherd') is a section of the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism, written in Aramaic. It presents teachings supposedly given by the soul of Moses. The cited passage discusses the structure of divine emanations and the relationship between different levels of spiritual reality.

[i] This is a reference to Daniel 2:38, where Nebuchadnezzar is described as the 'head of gold' in his first dream. The author creatively reinterprets this as representing the 'head of the structure of external forces,' meaning the chief of negative spiritual entities.

ובברוך שם כבוד מלכותו
לעולם ועד ג״כ שש תיבות יורה
כללות שש ספירות שביסוד
וכללותם י״ב שהם י״ב גבולי
אלכסון והאותיות הם בפסוק
שמע ישראל כ״ה יורה על
מציאות י׳ ספירות שכלולות
בחסד וי׳ שבגבורה וחמשה
שבת״ת עד ת״ת שבת״ת ושם עצם
הפסוק בסוד וא״ו ובבשכמ״לו
הם כ״ד אותיות נגד ד׳ ספירות
מת״ת שבת״ת עצמו ולמטה
ועשר בנצח ועשר בהוד הם כ״ד
והיסוד עצמו מקבל אותם שהוא
עצם הפסוק בסוד וא״ו וכלל
האותיות כלם הם מ״ט בסוד מ״ט
שערי בינה[i] וסודם מי דהיינו
סוד המקוה[ii] שפי׳ והם סוד מים
יו״ד עם מ״ם לכל סטר עוד
מ״ם סתומה עם י״ב נקודין לכל
סטר נקודה אמצעית שהיא שורש
לכל י״ב גבולים ונכלל בזה ב׳
מיני טהרות מ׳ סאה ט׳ קבין כי
הנקודות הם מ״ח ועם הנקודה
הם מ״ט. ויש עוד בחינה אחרת
מט׳ נקודין לכל סטר שהם סוד
מ׳ סאה עם הנקודה:[iii]

external forces. With this, you will understand the relationship between the first dream and the second, and how the structure of the external forces is destined to be annihilated, in the manner of "and the northern one I will remove far from you," etc. I have opened this small opening, and the wise person will see for himself how many directions it expands into, for this is not the place for such an inquiry.

Specifically, the verse of unification contains six words, indicating that they encompass the six sefirot within Tiferet. Similarly, in "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever" there are also six words, indicating the encompassing of the six sefirot within Yesod. Together they total twelve, corresponding to the twelve diagonal boundaries.[1] The letters in the verse "Hear, O Israel" number 25, indicating the existence of ten sefirot included in Chesed, ten in Gevurah, and five in Tiferet, up to Tiferet within Tiferet. The essence of the verse is in the mystery of the letter Vav.[A] In "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever," there are 24 letters, corresponding to four sefirot from Tiferet within Tiferet itself and below, plus ten in Netzach and ten in Hod, totaling 24. Yesod itself receives them, as it is the essence of the verse in the mystery of the letter Vav.

The total of all the letters is 49, corresponding

[A] Or: "in the mystery of the letter Vav (which represents the six directions and the divine attribute of Tiferet)" — This expanded translation provides important context about the letter Vav's mystical significance, which would be immediately understood by kabbalists but might not be clear to modern readers without this additional information.

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the twelve diagonal boundaries (gevulei alachson) that emerge from the permutations of the divine name YHVH and structure the cosmos according to Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), an early mystical text. These are visualized as diagonal lines connecting the six directions (north, south, east, west, up, down).

[i] According to rabbinic tradition, there are 50 gates of Understanding (Binah), but only 49 were revealed to Moses (Rosh Hashanah 21b). The author connects this concept to the 49 letters in the Shema and its response, suggesting that proper prayer might access these profound levels of divine wisdom.

[ii] The mikveh (ritual bath) serves as a mystical metaphor throughout this passage. Just as immersion in a physical mikveh purifies ritual impurity, the proper recitation of the Shema with appropriate mystical intentions purifies the divine structure from the effects of human sin.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4, Chapter 43 — This passage continues the discussion of the mystical significance of the Shema prayer begun in Chapter 42. Both sections present detailed Kabbalistic interpretations of this central Jewish prayer, explaining how proper recitation with specific mystical intentions (kavvanot) can create cosmic effects and unifications in the spiritual worlds. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd), Parashat Bo, folios 42-43 — The author explicitly references this section of the Zohar as containing foundational teachings about divine emanations, the structure of the spiritual worlds, and the relationships between various divine names and attributes. This citation provides the authoritative basis for many of the kabbalis-

to the 49 gates of Understanding (Binah), and their mystery is "Mi" [who/what], which is the mystery of the ritual bath as explained. They are the mystery of water: Yod with Mem for each direction, plus the closed Mem with 12 points for each direction, with a central point that is the root of all 12 boundaries. Included in this are two types of purifications: the 40 se'ah and the 9 kav, for the points number 48, and with the additional point they total 49. There is yet another aspect of 9 points for each direction, which is the mystery of the 40 se'ah with the point. 140R 145R 150R

פרק מ״ו

עוד בפסוק זה ג׳ שמות ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ הם י״ד אותיות וחלופם באבג״ד כוז״ו במוכס״ז כוז״ו והם ב׳ פעמים י״ד צרופם כ״ח שהם כ״ח אדנ״י דהיינו כ״ח אותיות משם אדנ״י במלואו ומלוי מילואו ואלו כ״ח הם ודאי לשכינה והם סוד י״ד עתים ללבנה מלאים וי״ד חסרים. ויכוין ליחד י״ד עם י״ד וכ״ח אותיות ג׳ שמות אלו עם חלופם ייחדם עם הכ״ח עליונים וכאשר יקשור ב׳ ידיו זו על זו יכוין בי״ד קשרים שבימין

Chapter 46

Additionally, in this verse, the three divine names "YHVH Eloheinu YHVH" contain 14 letters, and their substitution according to the ABGD [letter substitution] system is "KuZu BeMuKhSaZ KuZu."[A] These two sets of 14 letters combine to form 28, corresponding to the 28 letters of the divine name Adonai when spelled out in its full form and the filling of its filling. These 28 letters certainly correspond to the Shekhinah [Divine Presence] and represent the mystery of the 14 full and 14 deficient lunar cycles.[B1] 5R 10R

One should intend to unify the 14 with the 14, and the 28 letters of these three divine names with their substitutions, joining them with the 28 super-

[A] Or: "KUZU BMUKSZ KUZU" — This is an alternative transliteration that maintains the capital letters throughout, which some scholarly traditions prefer when rendering divine names or their substitutions. This might be preferred in contexts emphasizing the letter-by-letter correspondences with the Tetragrammaton.

[B] Or: "the 14 waxing and 14 waning phases of the moon" — This alternate translation emphasizes the cyclical nature of the lunar phases rather than the calendar months. While less precise in terms of Jewish calendar calculation, it might better convey the cosmic symbolism to readers unfamiliar with Jewish calendrical terminology.

[1] This refers to the lunar calendar, where months alternate between 29 days (deficient) and 30 days (full), creating a connection between cosmic cycles and divine names that reflects the kabbalistic principle that earthly phenomena mirror celestial patterns.

tic concepts presented in this passage. | Cf. Book of Daniel, Chapter 4 — The text references Nebuchadnezzar's second dream as a mystical allegory for understanding the structure of negative spiritual forces (kelipot) and how they will eventually be nullified. This creative interpretation of the biblical narrative demonstrates how the author incorporates scriptural references into his kabbalistic worldview. | Cf. Joel 2:20 — The author quotes this prophetic verse to support his assertion that the 'external forces' (negative spiritual entities) will eventually be destroyed. In kabbalistic literature, 'the northern one' is often associated with the forces of impurity and judgment. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — While not explicitly cited, this passage's detailed analysis of the numerical structure of the Shema prayer and its relationship to divine names draws heavily from concepts developed in Tikkunei Zohar, particularly the understanding of the prayer as a vehicle for unifying different aspects of divinity.

מיוחדים עם י״ד שבשמאל. עוד ידע כי הם י״ד אותיות שבעה ושבעה מוצקות ידו״ד אלה הם ז׳ ינ״ו ידו״ד הם ז׳ יכוין באומרו אחד הם ז׳ בז׳ מיוחדות ונקשרות.[i] עוד יכוין בדלי״ת של אחד שהיא גדולה. ורי״ש של אחר ג״כ גדולה לרמוז שאין לחצונים[ii] חלק ביחוד זה כלל כי אחדותו בלתי נקשר עם החצונים ואין נכללים באלהות דכתיב לא יגורך רע ח״ו. ובאומרו שמע יכוין למלכות שהיא פתח לכניסה ובה יתחנן אל הת״ת שהוא ישראל יבא אליה לשכון עמה וכדי לקשרם יחד יעלה לה׳ שהיא החכמה כלולית בה החסד והנצח ואח״כ יקשור החכמה עם הבינה שהוא אלהינו ויכוין שבקו הבינה יש הגבורה וההוד ואחר שיחד וזיוג גם הזווג עליון אבא ואמא ירד לזווג ברא וברתא ויכוין בה׳ שהוא הת״ת האוחז מהכתר ושם האין סוף שוכן ויורד דרך קו האמצעי כלול ימין ושמאל[iii] דרך הת״ת עד היסוד ואז יכוין אחד במלכות שהיא מיוחדת עם בעלה מחובקת בימין ושמאל ויכוין אח״כ במלת אחד על הא״ס שמבלעדיו אין אלהים ויקשור המלכות באין סוף סבה ראשונה ואח״כ בכתר ושם יודה כי מבלעדיו אין אלהים ועוד שהא״ס ראשון בחכמה וזהו בחינת המלכות בחכמה ויורד עמה מדרגה אחר

nal ones. When binding one's hands together, one should focus on the 14 joints of the right hand being unified with the 14 of the left hand.[1] One should also know that these 14 letters are divided into seven and seven: "YHVH" contributes seven, "ELoHeINU" contributes seven, and "YHVH" contributes seven more. When saying "Echad" [One], one should focus on these groups of seven being united and bound together. 15R 20R

One should also focus on the enlarged Dalet of "Echad," and similarly on the enlarged Resh of "Acher" [other], to indicate that the external forces have no part whatsoever in this unification, for His unity is not connected with the external forces, and they are not included in the Godhead, as it is written: "Evil shall not dwell with You," God forbid. 25R 30R

When saying "Shema" [Hear], one should focus on Malkhut [Kingdom], which is the entrance gate, and through it beseech Tiferet, which is "Israel," to come to dwell with her. To bind them together, one ascends to the [first] "YHVH," which is Chokhmah [Wisdom] that includes within it Chesed [Kindness] and Netzach [Victory]. Then one binds Chokhmah with Binah [Understanding], which is "Eloheinu," focusing on how the line of Binah contains Gevurah [Strength] and Hod [Splendor]. After unifying and coupling the supernal union of Abba and Imma [Father and Mother], one descends to couple the Son and Daughter, focusing on the [second] "YHVH," which is Tiferet that holds from Keter [Crown], where Ein Sof [the Infinite] dwells and descends through the central column, including right and left, through Tiferet to Yesod [Foundation]. 35R 40R 45R

Then one focuses on "Echad" [One] in relation to Malkhut, which is unified with her husband, em- 50R

[1] The human body is seen as a microcosm of divine structures. The 14 joints in each hand (3 in each of the 4 fingers plus 2 in the thumb) correspond to the 14 letters in the divine names, allowing the person praying to physically embody the cosmic unifications they are creating through prayer.

[i] The sevens referenced here relate to the kabbalistic understanding of cosmic structure, where groups of seven (such as the seven lower sefirot) create harmony when properly unified. This reflects the book's consistent emphasis on establishing proper balance and harmony during the soul's transition.

[ii] The 'external forces' (החצונים) refers to negative spiritual entities that, according to kabbalistic belief, attempt to interfere with the soul's journey, particularly at the moment of death. The enlarged letters in the Shema are seen as creating a mystical barrier against these forces.

[iii] This describes the kabbalistic concept of the 'middle pillar' or 'central column' of the sefirot, which balances the forces of mercy (right) and judgment (left). In the context of death rituals, this balance is crucial for the soul's peaceful transition.

מדרגה ויכוין שהוא אחרון
בבינה ששם אחדות הכל ושולט
ומנהיג עולמו ע״י חסד וגבורה
דהיינו דרום וצפון ומזרח ת״ת
ומערב מלכות ומטה ומעלה נ״ה
ויסוד כלול בין ת״ת ומלכות
דגוף וברית חשבינן חד והרי
המלכות נקשרת בשש קצוות עד
היסוד והוא הנהגת ושליטת אין
סוף בעולם ע״י הששה קצוות
והיינו סוד א׳ כתר ח׳ שמנה
ספירות ד׳ מלכות במקומה
פתח השער. ואח״כ מכוין כי
הא״ס מנהיג עולמו ע״י הספירות
אלו בזה כי היסוד מקבל הש
קצוות אלו שהם בת״ת הכוללם
וממציאם במלכות עצמה שהיא
כלולה ששה להנהיג העולם על
ידה והיינו ברוך יסוד מקבל
הספירות ומשפיען במלכות
והיינו אומרו שם כבוד מלכותו
והמלכות מנהגת העולם בכח
א״ס בהיותה משפעת שש קצוות
אלו בכסא הכבוד והיינו לעולם
שכסא הכבוד היא נקרא עולם
בבינה ששם שוכנת וכסא הכבוד
משפעת ע״י הא״ס שש קצוות אלו
בשבעה היכלות שהם היכל קדש
הקדשים והיכל הרצון ואהבה
וזכות ונגה ועצם השמים לבנת
הספיר והיינו ועד ו׳ שש היכלות
עד היכל אחרון שבכולם ומפני
ששם החצונים ממהר בכוונה
בזריזות לסלק היכל לבנת
הספיר ממדורו ששם רשעים
יתהלכון אל היכל עצם השמים
ושניהם לנגה ושלשתם אל היכל
הזכות וארבעתם אל היכל אהבה
ששם סוד יחוד קריאת שמע בסוד
האהבה ובן המלכות למעלה
בזה היא נקשרת עם החסד והיינו
ד׳ של ועד שהיא מלכות דלת
ושער והיא רומזת ד׳ היכלות
ובזה נגמר היחוד וקשר ההנהגה

braced by right and left. Afterward, with the word "Echad," one focuses on Ein Sof, besides whom there is no God, and binds Malkhut to Ein Sof, the First Cause, and then to Keter, acknowledging there that besides Him there is no God. Additionally, Ein Sof is first in Chokhmah, which is the aspect of Malkhut within Chokhmah, descending with it from level to level. One should focus on Him being last in Binah, where the unity of all exists, and He rules and guides His world through Chesed and Gevurah, which correspond to south and north, while east corresponds to Tiferet, west to Malkhut, down and up to Netzach and Hod, with Yesod included between Tiferet and Malkhut, for body and covenant are considered one. Thus, Malkhut is bound to the six extremities up to Yesod,[1] representing Ein Sof's governance and rule in the world through these six extremities. This is the secret of Alef [representing] Keter, Chet [representing] the eight Sefirot, and Dalet [representing] Malkhut in its place as the gateway.

Afterward, one focuses on how Ein Sof guides His world through these Sefirot: Yesod receives these six extremities that are included in Tiferet and brings them into Malkhut itself, which contains these six aspects to govern the world through it. This is [the meaning of] "Barukh" [Blessed]—Yesod receives the Sefirot and channels them into Malkhut, which is "Shem Kevod Malkhuto" [the Name of His glorious kingdom]. Malkhut governs the world through the power of Ein Sof by channeling these six extremities into the Throne of Glory, which is "le'olam" [forever], for the Throne of Glory is called "world" within Binah where it resides. The Throne of Glory, through Ein Sof, channels these six extremities into seven palaces: the Palace of the Holy of Holies, the Palace of Will, Love, Merit, Radiance, Essence of Heaven, and Sapphire Brick. This corresponds to "va'ed" [and ever], where the Vav represents six palaces up to the final palace among them.

Because the external forces are there, one must quickly and diligently focus on elevating the Palace of the Sapphire Brick from its dwelling place where the wicked walk, to the Palace of the Essence of Heaven, and both of them to Radiance, and all three

[1] The 'six extremities' refer to the six directional sefirot (Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, Netzach, Hod, and Yesod) that surround Malkhut. This geometric arrangement forms what kabbalists call the 'divine body,' and understanding this structure is crucial for creating proper unifications during prayer.

95 והשליט אין סוף בכל העולם ואמר החכם כי יחוד זה מבחר היחודים.[i] ועל דרך כלל במלת אחד בכללות רמ״ח תיבין ירמוז אל רמ״ח שייפין עילאין [ii]

to the Palace of Merit, and all four to the Palace of Love, where the secret of the Shema unification resides in the mystery of love. Similarly, Malkhut above is bound to Chesed through this, and this is the Dalet of "va'ed," which is Malkhut as gate and entrance, alluding to the four palaces. With this, the unification is completed, as is the binding of governance, and Ein Sof is established as ruler over the entire world. The sage said that this unification is the choicest of all unifications.

In general, the word "Echad" in its entirety, with its numerical value of 248,[1] alludes to the 248 supernal limbs.

95R 100R 105R

100 שהם בזכר רמ״ח ובנקבה רמ״ח נקשרים[iii] והכל אחד מיוחד ובזה יכוין לכלול רמ״ח אבריו[iv] ככל מה שיוכל שהוא בולל עצמו למעלה בסוד האהבה והוא

which are 248 in the male and 248 in the female,[2] bound together and all unified as one. With this intention, one should seek to include all 248 of one's limbs to the extent possible, encompassing oneself above in the mystery of love,

110R

[1]The Hebrew word 'Echad' (אחד) has a standard numerical value of 13, but the text is likely referring to the expanded meditation on this word, where contemplating all its mystical dimensions and connections creates a complete system corresponding to the 248 positive commandments and the 248 limbs of the human body.

[2]The text is describing the mystical correspondence between human anatomy and divine structure. The number 248 traditionally represents the number of positive commandments in the Torah as well as the number of limbs in the human body according to rabbinic tradition.

[i]The 'sage' referred to here is likely Rabbi Moses Cordovero, whose kabbalistic approach to prayer kavvanot (mystical intentions) is followed in this text, though with some integration of Lurianic concepts. The author shows familiarity with multiple kabbalistic systems of prayer meditation.

[ii]Cf. Shema Prayer — The passage provides kabbalistic instructions for proper mystical intentions (kavvanot) while reciting the Shema prayer, particularly at the time of death. These detailed meditations connect each word and letter of the prayer to the divine sefirot, creating a complete system of unifications between different aspects of divinity. | Cf. Zohar — This passage draws on and synthesizes Zoharic teachings about the mystical significance of the Shema prayer. The detailed system of unifications (yichudim) between divine names, sefirot, and cosmic forces reflects the Zohar's approach to transforming prayer into a cosmic act that affects all spiritual worlds. | Cf. Ana Bekoach prayer — The reference to letter substitution systems (KuZu BeMuKhSaZ KuZu) connects to the mystical 42-letter divine name that appears in the Ana Bekoach prayer, which is mentioned elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as an important component of deathbed rituals. | Cf. Lurianic Kabbalah — The elaborate system of kavvanot (mystical intentions) during prayer reflects the influence of Lurianic Kabbalah, which developed complex systems of meditation during prayer to create cosmic unifications. This passage appears to integrate both Cordoverian and Lurianic approaches to prayer mysticism.

[iii]The text states that both male and female have 248 limbs, which differs from some Talmudic sources that attribute different numbers to men and women. This equal attribution emphasizes the complementary nature of masculine and feminine aspects in the divine unity.

[iv]The mystical practice being described involves a mental exercise of incorporating one's entire physical being (all 248 limbs) into the spiritual act of prayer, creating a correspondence between the human body and the divine structure.

כלול ביחוד ורמ״ח אברים[i] הם
כללות עשר ספירות מיוחדות
כי הרמ״ח נכללים בראש שהם
שלש ראשונות וזרועות שהם
חסד וגדולה וגוף ת״ת ושוקין
וברית. וכמוהם בנקבה רמ״ח
והכל אחד בסוד קשר הספירות
ויחודם ביחוד ואחר שקשר
וייחד הכל יתחיל לעורר סוד
אהבה דהיינו ד׳ פרשיות ג״כ
כדפי׳. עוד בקצרה יכוין
בשמע ישראל ליחוד שכינתיה
עם קב״ה שהם ו״ה ה׳ אלהינו
ליחוד חכמה ובינה עצם אחד
שכל היחוד הזה מתייחד ע״י
הדעת בכח הכתר בחפץ אין סוף
ומושפע במלכות שהיא דלית
גדולה מאחד[ii] וביחוד מלכא
ומטרוניתא נכלל כל השעור
קומה שהוא מחסד ולמטה כי
ראוי לדעת שהספירות הם ו׳
פעולות מתפשטות מא״ס דבוקות
בנו ראשם העליון יכולה בשם
זכרים שהם משפיעים והם רחמים
מפני קורבתם באין סוף וסופם
הדבוקות בנו הם נקבה ודין
והם מושפעות וקצה העליון

and one is included in the unification.[A] These
248 limbs encompass the totality of the ten unified
sefirot, for the 248 are included in the head, 115R
which represents the three highest sefirot, and the
arms, which represent Chesed (Loving-kindness)
and Gedulah (Greatness), and the body, which
is Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), and the thighs and
the covenant (genitalia). Similarly, the female 120R
has 248 limbs, and all is one in the mystery of
the binding of the sefirot[1] and their unification
in unity. After binding and unifying everything,
one should begin to awaken the mystery of love,
meaning the four Torah portions,[2] as explained. 125R
Additionally, in brief, when reciting "Hear O Israel,"
one should intend the unification of God's Divine
Presence with the Holy One, blessed be He, which
are represented by the letters Vav-Hei. The words
"The LORD our God" represent the unification of 130R
Chokhmah (Wisdom) and Binah (Understanding)
as one essence, for this entire unification is unified
through Da'at (Knowledge)[B] by the power of Keter
(Crown) through the desire of the Ein Sof (Infinite
One), and flows into Malkhut (Kingdom), which 135R
is the enlarged Dalet in the word "One."[3] In the
unification of the King and Queen is included the
entire divine structure[C] from Chesed downward.
For it is proper to know that the sefirot are six

[A] Or: "encompassed in the divine unity" — This alternative translation emphasizes the mystical nature of the unification being described, making it clearer that this is a divine process rather than a mundane joining.

[B] Or: "unified through Da'at, the connecting principle" — This alternative better captures the function of Da'at in Kabbalistic thought as the principle that connects the upper and lower sefirot.

[C] Or: "mystical dimensions of the divine form" — The concept of 'Shi'ur Komah' refers to the mystical dimensions and measurements of the divine body in Jewish mysticism. This alternative provides more context about this complex concept.

[1] The text uses the metaphor of 'binding' (kesher) to describe how the ten divine emanations (sefirot) are interconnected and how human intention during prayer can affect their relationships.

[2] This refers to the four biblical passages contained in tefillin (phylacteries): Exodus 13:1-10, Exodus 13:11-16, Deuteronomy 6:4-9, and Deuteronomy 11:13-21. In kabbalistic thought, these represent different aspects of divine unity.

[3] In the Hebrew text of the Shema prayer, the last letter of the word 'echad' (one) is traditionally written larger than the other letters. This enlarged Dalet carries significant mystical meaning, representing Malkhut (Kingdom), the divine attribute that interfaces with our world.

[i] The number 248 corresponds to the traditional count of limbs in the human body according to rabbinic literature. This number also corresponds to the number of positive commandments in the Torah. The parallel between human anatomy and divine structure is a fundamental concept in Jewish mysticism.

[ii] This refers to the enlarged letter Dalet (ד) in the word 'echad' (אחד—one) at the end of the Shema prayer. In kabbalistic tradition, this enlarged letter has special significance, representing Malkhut (Kingdom), the divine attribute that interfaces with our world.

הדבק בא״ס יכונה בשם מלכא וקצה התחתון הדבק בנו יכונה מטרוניתא ובן קצה העליון יכונה קוב״ה והתחתון בשם שבינתיה ועקר הכוונה לקשר ב׳ קצוות ליחדם יחד[i][ii]

actions extending from the Ein Sof,[1] attached to us. Their upper ends are called by masculine names, for they bestow influence and represent mercy due to their proximity to the Ein Sof. Their lower ends, which are attached to us, are feminine and represent judgment, and they receive influence. The upper end that cleaves to the Ein Sof is called by the name "King," and the lower end that cleaves to us is called "Queen." Similarly, the upper end is called "the Holy One, blessed be He," and the lower end is called "His Divine Presence." The essential intention is to bind these two extremities, unifying them together. 140R 145R 150R

והיינו סוד ידו״ד אדנ״י ויחודם שם בן ח׳ חותיות ב׳ שמות אלו משולבים יחד בסוד נעוץ סופם בתחלתם[iii] וכו׳ וזהו שמים זכר וארץ נקבה[iv] והם שש בחינות נגד שש בחינות סוד הנהגת ששת ימים וששת לילות בבחינות הנקבות ויום שבת מנהיג סוד קשר תפארת מלכות עם הבינה[v] דהיינו יום

And this is the mystery of YHVH-ADNY and their unification as an eight-letter Name,[2] these two Names interwoven together in the secret of "their end is wedged in their beginning," and so forth. This represents heaven as male and earth as female, and these are six aspects corresponding to six aspects—the secret of the governance of the six days and six nights in the feminine aspects. And the Sabbath day governs the secret bond of Tiferet-Malkhut with Binah, meaning the seventh 155R 160R

[1] The text refers specifically to the six lower sefirot (from Chesed to Yesod), excluding the higher triad (Keter, Chokhmah, Binah) and Malkhut. These six are often treated as a unit in kabbalistic thought, representing the primary active divine forces in creation.

[2] The text refers to the combination of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH, four letters) and the divine name ADNY (four letters), which together form an eight-letter name. This combined name is central to kabbalistic practices, particularly in prayer and at the time of death.

[i] This summarizes the entire purpose of kabbalistic prayer: to unify the higher and lower aspects of divinity. This unification (yichud) is seen as repairing cosmic separation and restoring harmony to all worlds.

[ii] Cf. Shema Yisrael prayer — The text explains the kabbalistic intentions (kavvanot) for reciting the Shema prayer, especially at the time of death, showing how this prayer serves as a vehicle for unifying various divine aspects and ultimately uniting the soul with its divine source. | Cf. Zohar — The passage draws heavily on Zoharic concepts of divine unification, particularly the joining of masculine and feminine divine aspects (Holy One and Divine Presence) through proper intention during prayer. | Cf. Four Portions of the Tefillin — The text refers to 'four portions' (arba parshiyot) which likely refers to the four Torah passages placed in tefillin. In kabbalistic thought, tefillin are seen as instruments for divine unification. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Chapter 42 — This passage continues the book's detailed explanation of mystical intentions during prayer, especially at the time of death, connecting to earlier discussions about the proper spiritual focus for the Shema recitation.

[iii] This phrase refers to the mystical principle from Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) that describes cyclical reality where endings connect back to beginnings. Applied to divine names, it suggests the interwoven, circular nature of divine unity.

[iv] This reflects the fundamental kabbalistic concept that the cosmos is structured as a dynamic interplay between masculine and feminine divine principles, where heaven represents the masculine aspect and earth the feminine.

[v] In Kabbalah, the Sabbath represents a unique cosmic state where Tiferet (the central, harmonizing divine attribute) and Malkhut (the divine presence in the world) connect with Binah (divine understanding), creating a complete unified structure.

שביעי נקודה אמצעית לכל
הספירות. ובפרשה ואתחנן
150 הרחיב הזהר בפירוש היחוד.
ובסוד המזוזה הפליג לדבר שם
בדף רס״ה ורס״ו וגם המצוה
הזאת הוא סיוע לטהרת האדם
בעה״ז ובעה״ב.[i] וכבר אמרנו
155 למעלה כי גם שלא ידע האדם
לכוין במצות ויחודים שעושה
בשלימות אם יהיה לו כוונה
טובה ה׳ יגמור על ידו. וכתוב
בפ׳ יתרו דף צ״ה קוב״ה בעי
160 לבא ורעותא דבר נש[ii] ואפ״ה
אי לאו תמן רעותא דלבא דאיהו
עקרא דכלא על דא צלי דוד
ואמר ומעשה ידינו כוננה עלינו
דלית כל ברנש חכים לשוואה
165 רעותא ולבא לתקנא כלא וע״ד
אמר כוננה עלינו את כוננה
ואתקון תקונך לעילא בדקא
יאות עלינו אע״ג דלית אנן ידעין
לשוואה רעותא אלא עובדא
170 בלחודוהי מעשה ידינו כוננהו
לההוא דרגא דאצטריך לאתקנא
כוננהו בחבורא חדא כאבהן
למיהוי מתקנא בהון בהאי
עובדא בדקא יאות. עזרנו אלהי
175 ישענו שיתקדש ויתייחד על ידינו
לעולם ועד ויחד לבבנו לעבדך
באמת ולהודות לשמך כי טוב
עם כל ישראל ונזכה לחיי עד
א״ס:[iii]

day is the central point for all the sefirot.[1] In the portion Va'etchanan, the Zohar expands on the explanation of this unification. And regarding the 165R
secret of the mezuzah, it discusses this extensively on pages 265 and 266. This commandment also assists in the purification of a person in this world and in the World to Come. We have already stated above
that even if a person does not know how to direct 170R
his intention perfectly in the commandments and unifications he performs, if he has good intention, the Lord will complete it through him. And it is written in the portion Yitro, page 95: "The Holy
One, blessed be He, desires the heart and will of 175R
a person. Nevertheless, if the will of the heart, which is the essence of everything, is not there, David prayed about this and said, 'Establish the work of our hands upon us,' for not every person is
wise enough[2] to direct his will and heart to rectify 180R
everything. Therefore he said, 'Establish upon us'—You establish and arrange Your rectification above as is fitting for us, even though we do not know how to direct our intention, but only the
action itself. 'The work of our hands, establish 185R
it'—for that level which needs to be rectified, establish it in a single unified connection, like the Patriarchs,[3] so that it may be properly rectified through this action." Help us, God of our salvation,
that Your Name be sanctified and unified through 190R
us forever and ever, and unite our hearts to serve You in truth and to give thanks to Your name, for it is good, with all Israel, and may we merit eternal life, Ein Sof.[4]

[1] The seventh day (Sabbath) is described as a nexus point that connects different levels of divine reality, particularly bringing together Tiferet (the central balancing attribute), Malkhut (divine presence in the world), and Binah (divine understanding/the supernal mother).

[2] This reflects a key theological principle in Ma'avar Yabok: that while precise mystical intentions are ideal, sincere devotion is sufficient for effective prayer, especially in contexts like deathbed rituals where technical kabbalistic knowledge might be lacking.

[3] The reference to the Patriarchs suggests that one's actions can be elevated to the spiritual level of the biblical forefathers even without perfect understanding, if performed with proper intention and divine assistance.

[4] Ein Sof (literally 'without end') is the kabbalistic term for God's infinite, unknowable essence

[i] The text indicates that proper mystical intention in prayer, particularly understanding the unification of divine names, has purifying effects not only in this world but also in the World to Come, suggesting its particular importance in deathbed contexts.

[ii] This Zoharic teaching emphasizes that God primarily desires the sincere heart and will of a person, rather than technical perfection in religious practices—a comforting message for those attending to the dying.

[iii] Cf. Zohar Va'etchanan — The author is referencing the Zohar's explanation of divine unification through the Shema prayer, which is central to Jewish mystical practice, particularly at the time of death as discussed in this portion of Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Zohar Yitro — The author quotes

ב״ה תם חלק שלישי מספר
מעבר יבק הנקרא שפתי
רננות[i] ובעה״י נתחיל חלק
רביעי ממנו אשר יקרא בישראל
שמו עתר ענן הקטרת[ii] אהיה
כטל לישראל[iii] ואת הצפוני
ארחיק מעליכם[iv] וגילו ושמחו
בה׳ אלהיכם:[vi] [v]

With God's help,[1] the third part of the book Ma'avar Yabok called "Siftei Renanot" (Lips of Joyous Song) is completed, and with God's help we will begin the fourth part of it which shall be called in Israel by the name "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (Cloud of Incense Prayer[2]). "I will be like dew to Israel[3] and I will remove the northern one from you,[4] and rejoice and be glad in the LORD your God."

beyond all attributes. The prayer concludes by expressing hope for eternal life connected to this divine infinity.

[1]The Hebrew abbreviation בעה״י (be'ezrat Hashem yitbarakh) literally means 'with the help of God, may He be blessed,' a common formula in traditional Jewish texts acknowledging divine assistance.

[2]The Hebrew title 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' uses three terms related to prayer and Temple ritual: 'eter' (supplication/prayer), 'anan' (cloud), and 'ketoret' (incense). This creates a rich metaphor comparing prayer to the rising smoke of the Temple incense offering, which was considered particularly powerful for gaining divine favor.

[3]This biblical quotation from Hosea suggests that the upcoming section on prayer and incense will provide spiritual refreshment like dew provides physical refreshment to plants, especially appropriate in the arid climate of Israel where dew is essential for plant survival.

[4]In this context, 'the northern one' (hatzefoni) likely carries its kabbalistic meaning of negative spiritual forces or the evil inclination. The author is suggesting that the prayer practices in the upcoming section will help remove these harmful influences.

this passage to reassure the reader that even imperfect spiritual intentions can be effective if one's heart is sincere, which is particularly relevant for those attending to the dying who may not fully understand all the mystical kavvanot. | Cf. Psalm 90:17 — The Zohar passage cited by the author interprets this verse as a prayer for divine assistance in spiritual practices when human intention is incomplete, suggesting that divine grace completes what human effort begins. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The author references this principle to explain how the divine names YHVH and ADNY interlock in a cyclical unity, representing the integration of masculine and feminine divine aspects.

[i]This is the title of the third section of Ma'avar Yabok, meaning 'Lips of Joyous Song' or 'Lips of Praise,' which deals with prayers for the dead and teachings about the afterlife.

[ii]This is the title of the fourth section, meaning 'Cloud of Incense Prayer,' which focuses on prayer as a spiritual substitute for the Temple incense offering (ketoret). This title combines 'eter' (prayer/supplication), 'anan' (cloud), and 'ketoret' (incense), evoking the imagery of prayer rising like incense smoke.

[iii]A quotation from Hosea 14:6, where God promises to be like refreshing dew to Israel, symbolizing divine blessing and spiritual renewal.

[iv]A quotation from Joel 2:20, where God promises to remove 'the northern one' (traditionally understood as an invading army or plague). In Kabbalistic interpretation, 'the northern one' (tzfoni) often represents evil forces or the evil inclination, as 'north' was associated with darkness and judgment.

[v]A quotation from Joel 2:23, completing the previous reference, where the removal of 'the northern one' leads to rejoicing in God. This suggests that the practices described in the upcoming section will lead to spiritual joy through the removal of negative influences.

[vi]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This is the concluding statement of the third section of Ma'avar Yabok, indicating the completion of the section titled 'Siftei Renanot' (Lips of Joyous Song) and announcing the beginning of the fourth section titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer). | Cf. Hosea 14:6 — The phrase 'I will be like dew to Israel' is quoted from Hosea 14:6, where God promises to restore Israel. This metaphor of divine blessing as life-giving dew is particularly appropriate as the author transitions to a section about prayer and incense offerings, which are meant to draw down divine blessing. | Cf. Joel 2:20-23 — This phrase combines elements from Joel 2:20 ('I will remove the northern one far from you') and Joel 2:23 ('rejoice and be glad in the LORD your God'). In Joel, 'the northern one' refers to a destructive army or plague that God promises to remove, followed by restoration and rejoicing. In kabbalistic context, 'the northern

one' (צפוני) often refers to evil forces or the evil inclination, as north was traditionally associated with darkness and judgment.

Part III

Discourses on daily purity

Discourse 6

עתר ענן הקטורת / Prayer of the Incense Cloud

פרק א׳ — Chapter 1

חלק ראשון[i] — The First Part

אלהים חילי[ii] ישלח עזרי מקדש אכי״ר.[iii][iv] — May God, my strength,[1] send my help from the sanctuary.[2] Amen.

ואחזה אנכי אשית אל לבי לכתוב שלישים במועצות מדעת שפתי אשר ימללו במאמרי זה הרדביעי[v] אשר יפרד לשלשה — I shall now set my heart to write threefold wisdom[3] with thoughtful counsel from the utterances of my lips in this fourth discourse, which divides into three parts. The first part turns toward the 5R

[1] The Hebrew 'חילי' (cheili) can be translated as 'my strength' or 'my might.' It appears in biblical passages like Habakkuk 3:19.
[2] The Hebrew 'מקדש' (mikdash) refers to the sanctuary or holy place, often referring to the Temple in Jerusalem in biblical contexts.
[3] The Hebrew 'לכתוב שלישים' literally means 'to write thirds' or 'to write threefold things,' which may allude to Proverbs 22:20. The term suggests writing of exceptional wisdom or writing in three parts.

[i] This is the title designating the opening section of the fourth discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer). This section focuses on prayer as a substitute for Temple incense offerings.
[ii] This phrase combines elements from two biblical verses: "God is my strength" (חילי) from Habakkuk 3:19 and "May He send your help from the sanctuary" (ישלח עזרך מקדש) from Psalm 20:3.
[iii] This is an acronym for 'Amen Ken Yehi Ratzon' (אמן כן יהי רצון), meaning 'Amen, so may it be [God's] will'—a common concluding formula in Hebrew prayers.
[iv] Cf. Psalm 20:3 — The author begins with an invocation for divine assistance from God's holy place, establishing a connection to biblical precedent for seeking divine help in times of need. This creates a sacred frame for the text that follows. | Cf. Habakkuk 3:19 — By drawing on Habakkuk's declaration of divine strength, the author positions himself as reliant on God's power rather than his own abilities, establishing a tone of humility appropriate for a work on such serious matters as death and the afterlife.
[v] The term 'discourse' (מאמר) is used consistently throughout Ma'avar Yabok to refer to its major sections. This is specifically identified as the fourth discourse.

ראשים[i] הראש האחד יפנה
דרך קרן בן שמן להעלות
קטרת בשמים וקדה על כל
סדר עבודה. ומשם יביע אומר
ובמאזנים ישא יחד. זכו"ת
ומישו"ר.[ii] הראש השני זכותא
דרבים עדיפא ליה בנפש כי
תחטא למצוא מזור לה ברפואות
תעלה בקרבן תענית[iii] ורוח
נכאה וישב בדד עם מלכו וידום
מכל דברי שיחה קלה. והראש
השלישי משרי"ם אהב ליקח מן
הבא בידו מחומת אנ"ך[iv] מנחה
ותשורה לקונו וישתפך עליו
נפשו ושיח רנתו עולת תמיד
בבקר ובערב במנחתו של
אהרן[v] אשר כליל תקטר מחציתה
בבקר ומחציתה בערב. הנה
כי עתר ענן הקטרת[vi] יעלה עם
קרבן תענית. ומנחתו של אהרן.
ובאלהים נעשה חיל ויגדל נא
כח אדני כי יערב עליו שיחנו
ואלהים יחננו ויברכנו יאר פניו

path of the horn of oil[1] to offer incense and fragrant spices for every order of divine service. From there it shall express its word and weigh together in the 10R
scales: Merit and Uprightness.[2] The second part [teaches that] the merit of the many is preferable for the soul that has sinned, to find healing through remedies of recovery in the sacrifice of fasting, with a contrite spirit, sitting alone with one's King in 15R
silence, refraining from all light conversation. And the third part loves Righteousness, taking from what comes to hand from the wall of Scripture[3] as an offering and gift to one's Creator. One's soul pours itself out in prayerful meditation, [like] the continual 20R
burnt offering in morning and evening, like Aaron's meal offering[4] which is entirely burned—half in the morning and half in the evening. Thus the cloud of incense prayer[5] rises together with the sacrifice of fasting and Aaron's offering. Through God we shall 25R
gain strength, and may the power of the Lord be magnified, for our meditation shall be pleasing to Him. May God be gracious to us and bless us; may He cause His face to shine upon us, Selah.

[1]The phrase 'דרך קרן בן שמן' is difficult to translate literally. It may refer to the horn used for anointing with oil (as in 1 Samuel 16:1), metaphorically suggesting a path of consecration or elevation.

[2]The terms 'זכו"ת ומישו"ר' appear with quotation marks in the original, suggesting they may be technical terms or have special significance in the author's system of thought.

[3]The phrase 'מחומת אנ"ך' is a play on the acronym ANaKh (Torah, Prophets, and Writings), metaphorically presenting Scripture as a protective wall from which spiritual materials can be drawn.

[4]The author may be making a wordplay on his own name (Aaron Berechia of Modena) by referring to 'Aaron's offering,' thus inserting himself into the tradition of priestly service through his literary work.

[5]The phrase 'עתר ענן הקטרת' combines prayer (עתר), cloud (ענן), and incense (קטרת) to create a rich metaphor for prayer as a spiritual equivalent to Temple incense offerings. This is also the title of this fourth discourse.

[i]The author is employing biblical language from Genesis 2:10 ('and from there it divided and became four heads') to describe the structure of his work, suggesting that his writing, like the rivers of Eden, flows from a divine source and branches into multiple streams of wisdom.

[ii]The words are written with quotation marks, possibly indicating they form an acronym or have special mystical significance beyond their literal meaning.

[iii]This term conceptualizes fasting as a sacrifice, suggesting that voluntary self-denial is a spiritual equivalent to Temple offerings, a concept developed in post-Temple rabbinic literature.

[iv]ANaKh is an acronym for the three divisions of the Hebrew Bible: Torah (Pentateuch), Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings). The phrase 'from the wall of Scripture' metaphorically presents biblical verses as building blocks of spiritual practice.

[v]This is a reference to the meal offering that Aaron and his sons were commanded to offer, as described in Leviticus 6:12-16. The author may also be creating a wordplay with his own name (Aaron Berechia of Modena).

[vi]This phrase, which combines 'eter' (prayer/supplication), 'anan' (cloud), and 'ketoret' (incense), is the title of this fourth discourse of Ma'avar Yabok.

אתנו סלה:[i]

האל השם בחיים נפשנו ובטובו
השביענו כתב בתורתו זאת
התורה לעולה ולמנחה וגו׳
ודרשו חז״ל על פסוק זה כי
התורה במקום עולה וכו׳[ii] אין
ספק כי ע״י העולה ושאר
הקרבנות היה האור העליון
מתגלה ומתאחדים האותיות
שהם המדרגות עליונות. וזהו
קרבן לה׳. פירוש יחוד וקירוב
אותיות יד״וד[iii] ובהיות האדם
עוסק בתורה התורה והאותיות
ההם נאצלות מהמקום ההוא
אשר בו פעולת העונה או המנחה
או הקטרת המקשר כל הצורות
בסוד מיני בוסמין שבו ונודע
שמהבל פה התורה נעשה מכל
אות ואות מלאך וכח רוחני
המתהוה באויר מהבל פיו היוצא
שיש בו ממש כמו שנראה לעין
בימי החורף ומלאך זה מסתלק
מדרגה אחר מדרגה עד שמתדבק
ומעורר שורש הענין ההוא בעשן
נר התחתון שמדליק הנר העליון
המוקבל לה. וכמשל שני מיני.
נגונים זה כנגד זה שבנגן התחתון

God, who maintains our souls in life and in His goodness satisfies us, wrote in His Torah: "This is the law for the burnt offering, for the meal offering, etc." Our Sages of blessed memory taught concerning this verse that Torah study serves in place of the sacrificial offerings. Undoubtedly, through the burnt offering and other sacrifices, the supernal light was revealed and the letters—which represent the higher spiritual levels—were unified. This is the meaning of "an offering to the LORD"[1]—namely, the unification and drawing together of the letters of the Divine Name YHVH.

When a person engages in Torah study, the Torah and its letters emanate from the same spiritual source where the burnt offering, meal offering, or incense offering would have their effect—the incense particularly binding all forms together through the mystery of its aromatic ingredients. It is known that from the breath of Torah study,[2] each and every letter creates an angel and spiritual force that takes form in the air from the breath that leaves one's mouth, which has actual substance, as can be seen in winter when breath is visible. This angel ascends from one level to the next until it cleaves to and awakens the root of that particular matter, like the smoke from a lower candle that

[1] The Hebrew term "korban" (offering) is being interpreted through its etymology from the root meaning "to draw near" (karov), explaining that sacrifices create spiritual proximity or unification of divine names.

[2] The Hebrew "hevel peh haTorah" refers to the actual breath that emerges when one speaks words of Torah. In kabbalistic thought, this breath has concrete spiritual reality and creates angels and spiritual forces.

[i] Cf. Psalms 67:2 — The author employs this verse as a prayer for divine assistance in his literary endeavor, following the biblical tradition of invoking divine blessing at the beginning of significant undertakings. | Cf. Numbers 28:4-8 — The author is creating a metaphorical connection between his literary work and the Temple sacrificial system, suggesting that his writings serve as spiritual substitutes for physical offerings, a common theme in post-Temple rabbinic literature. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok itself — This passage serves as a meta-textual introduction to the fourth discourse, explaining how it will be structured and what themes each section will address. The three parts correspond to: 1) incense offerings and prayer, 2) fasting as spiritual remedy, and 3) scripture-based offerings of devotion. | Cf. Leviticus 6:12-16 — This references the priestly meal offering described in Leviticus, creating a connection between the author's written work and the Temple service, positioning his spiritual writings as substitutes for physical offerings.

[ii] This refers to the rabbinic teaching that since the destruction of the Temple, Torah study concerning sacrifices serves as a spiritual substitute for the actual offerings themselves. This appears in Talmud Menachot 110a.

[iii] The term "יד״וד" is a substitute for writing the Tetragrammaton (the four-letter divine name YHVH). The text explains that the word "korban" (offering) is related to the root "karov" (to draw near), suggesting that sacrifices spiritually draw together the letters of God's name.

ינגן העליון כי מכח שבירת
האויר שעושה התחתון יפעל
גם בעליון המוגבל נגדו כאשר
העלו המפרשים בספריהם. א״כ
בהיות האדם עוסק בתורה בסדר
העולה או המנחה או בפסוקי
וסדר פטום הקטרת וכיוצא
נותן את כוונתו להשלים המדות
העליונות מצד כח נשמתו ורוחו
ונפשו המתעצל מהם וששורש כל
אחד מהם בהם למעלה ואחר
שהנשמות מציאותם מהשרשים
עליונים חייבים אנו להמשיך
במדות כפי נשמותינו ושמא
זו סיבת בריאתנו והוא כמי
שבידיו מטלטל המאצטי״צי
של מאניקור״דו[i] שגם שיהיו
בחדר אחת ינגן הכלי שיר
מכחו במקום שהוא ע״י אחיזתו
בבתי ידים שלו גם שרחוקים
ממנו. ועוד כי אדם צל ודוגמת
העליונים[ii] וכמו שכל מה שיעשה
האדם יתראה בצל כן כל מה
שיפעול או ידבר האדם למטה
בנגדו יתפעל ויאמר למעלה אם
לטוב אם למוטב ולכן המרים
יד על חבירו אפי׳ בהרמה
בעלמא נקרא רשע שכבר נתראה
למעלה בכח נשמתו הרעת
ידו ואפי׳ המחשבה הנעלמת
למטה מתגלים ומתראית למעלה
במקום המחשבה העליונית
ולהיות כי אין שום מלאך וכ״ש
מה שלמטה ממנו שיהיה הבוחן

kindles a higher candle aligned above it.[1]

This is comparable to two similar musical instruments positioned opposite each other: when the lower one is played, the upper one will also resonate, because the vibration of air caused by the lower instrument affects the upper one aligned with it, as commentators have explained in their works. Therefore, when a person studies the Torah passages concerning the burnt offering, meal offering, or the verses and order of the incense preparation and similar topics, they direct their intention to perfect the supernal attributes through the power of their soul, spirit, and vital force which derive from these attributes, with the root of each of these being above. And since souls exist from supernal roots, we are obligated to extend influence to the divine attributes according to our souls, and perhaps this is the very purpose of our creation.

This is like someone who manipulates the keys of a harpsichord,[2] where even if the instrument is in one room, it plays music by his power in the place where he is, through his control of the keyboard, even though they are distant from each other. Furthermore, a human being is a shadow and reflection of the supernal realms, and just as whatever a person does is visible in their shadow, so too whatever a person does or speaks below correspondingly affects and resonates above, whether for good or for ill. This is why one who raises a hand against his fellow, even if merely lifting it without striking, is called wicked, for the harm of his hand has already been perceived above through the power of his soul. Even hidden thoughts below are revealed and visible above in the place of supernal thought.

60R 65R 70R 75R 80R 85R

[1] This metaphor illustrates the kabbalistic concept of correspondence between lower and higher realms. Just as smoke rises from a lower candle to light an upper one, so too the words and intentions of human prayer and study rise to affect the divine realms.

[2] I've rendered the unusual terms "מאצטי״צי של מאניקור״דו" as "harpsichord" based on context. The author appears to be using the mechanical action of a keyboard instrument, where pressing keys in one location causes strings to vibrate elsewhere, as a metaphor for how human actions below affect divine realms above.

[i] These unusual terms refer to parts of a harpsichord or similar stringed instrument. The author is using the mechanical action of a keyboard instrument, where pressing keys in one location causes strings to vibrate elsewhere, as a metaphor for how human actions below affect divine realms above.

[ii] This expresses the kabbalistic principle that humans are created in the divine image and function as a microcosm reflecting the macrocosm of divine attributes. The author uses the metaphor of a shadow to explain how human actions below create corresponding movements in the divine realm above.

לבות וכליות אלא אלהים צדיק.
לכן המחשבה רעה אי אפשר
שתצורף למעשה[i] דבשלמא
הצטיירות המחשבה טובה
שעתידה להצטייר למעלה
בקדושה במקום המחשבות
תגלה ותתראה וזה סוד הרהורי
תשובה המועילים לאדם ולכן
הרהורי מצוה מקדשים מחשבתו
של אדם ובתר רישא גופא אזיל
וכ״ש הדבור אבל המחשבה
רעה שהיה צריך שתצייר בכחות
החיצונים והם לא ידעו מחשבות
אדם ואין לה הויה והיה כלא
היה. והנה בהיות אדם עוסק
בתורת קרבנות וכוונתו להעביר
מן המדות החלודה שגרם במעשיו
אין ספק שאותם האותיות יפעלו
למעלה פעולה נפלאת ובתשובה
יסלק המשטין ותחת רוח טועים
יכנס רוח טהרה בנשמתו ובכח
האותיות יתעורר השפע עליון
ויאיר מקום החשוך בעונותיו
ובזה נמצא תורה במקום עולה
בכל פנותיה ולהיות כי ליחוד
הגדול שאדם מזדמן לעשות
בתפלתו צריך טהרה גדולה
מעונותיו ללבן ולצרף נפשו
לכן הקדימו בבקר וגם בערב
קצת סדר הקרבנות כדי שיטהר
אדם עצמו בהם ואחר הטהרה
תבא הקדושה כדכתיב וטהרו
וקדשו ואין תשמיש חביב בכל
הקרבנות בקטרת[ii] כאשר יבא
לפנינו ובגדולת ערכו יהיו
עסקנו בחלק הזה בעזה״י. אך
תחלה נשיב ידינו על מנהגי

Since no angel—and certainly nothing below an angel—can examine hearts and minds except the righteous God,[1] an evil thought cannot be joined with action. Whereas the formation of good thoughts, which are destined to be formed above in holiness in the realm of thoughts, will be revealed and made manifest—this is the secret of how thoughts of repentance benefit a person. Therefore, thoughts of fulfilling commandments sanctify a person's mind, and "the body follows the head," all the more so with speech. But an evil thought, which would need to be formed among the external forces, cannot be, for they do not know human thoughts, and thus it has no existence and is as if it never was.

When a person engages in the Torah of sacrifices with the intention of removing the rust from the divine attributes caused by their deeds, without doubt those letters will have a wondrous effect above. Through repentance, they will remove the accuser, and in place of a spirit of error, a spirit of purity will enter their soul.[2] Through the power of these letters, divine flow will be aroused and illuminate the place darkened by their sins. In this way, Torah study truly functions in place of a sacrifice in all its aspects.

Since the great unification that a person prepares to make in their prayer requires significant purification from sins to refine and purify their soul, our Sages established that we recite some of the sacrificial order in the morning and evening, so that a person may purify themselves through them. After purification comes sanctification, as it is written, "They shall purify and sanctify." Among all the sacrifices, none is as beloved as the incense offering, as we shall explain further, and we shall occupy ourselves with its greatness in this section, with God's help. But first, let us turn our attention to the prayer customs

[1] This references Psalm 7:10, "God who examines hearts and minds is righteous." The author uses this to explain why evil thoughts have no spiritual existence in higher realms.

[2] The contrast between "ruach to'im" (spirit of error) and "ruach taharah" (spirit of purity) draws on the mystical concept that different spiritual qualities can inhabit a person based on their actions and intentions.

[i] The author makes a significant kabbalistic point that evil thoughts cannot manifest spiritually in the same way as good thoughts, because the "external forces" (negative spiritual entities) cannot access human thoughts, which are known only to God. This is why thoughts of repentance and commandments have spiritual efficacy while evil thoughts remain without spiritual existence.

[ii] The author states that among all sacrificial offerings, none is as beloved or effective as the incense (ketoret) offering. This establishes the importance of the Ketoret prayer that will be the focus of this section of Ma'avar Yabok.

[i] התפלה הנאמרת בבית האבל

ולמה משמטים מסדרה כמה דברים. כבר נהגו בכל גלילות אלו להתפלל בבית האבל וסמכו דבריהם על הא דאמר רב יהודה[ii] מת שאין לו מנחמים באים עשרה בני אדם ויושבים במקומו. ואמרי׳ נמי ההוא דשכיב בשבובתא דרב דלא הוו ליה מנחמי כל יומא הוה מכניף רב יהודה עשרה ואזיל ויתיב אדוכתיה לבתר שבעה יומין אתחזי ליה בחלמיה וא״ל תנוח דעתך שהנחת את דעתי. וכתבו דמסתברא מדהוה טרח לכנופי שם עשרה שמע מינה להתפלל שם קעביד וגם בברייתא דרבי אליעזר פרק י״ז נמצא וכשחרב בית המקדש התקינו חכמים שיהיו אבלים וחתנים הולכים לבית הכנסת ולמדרשות וכו׳ מ״מ בגמ׳ דילן מוכח שהאבל שבת ראשונה אינו יוצא מפתח ביתו אפי׳ לילך לב״ח. ובהתפללם בביתו אין מתחילים אלא מברוך שאמר[iii] וא״א השירה[iv] וסמכו זה על מה שאמרו במסכת מגילה

observed in a house of mourning.

And why are several elements omitted from the prayer service [in a house of mourning]? It has already become customary in all these regions to pray in the house of mourning,[1] and they based their practice on what Rav Yehudah said: "If a deceased person has no comforters, ten men come and sit in his place." And it is also said regarding one who died in Rav's neighborhood who had no comforters, that every day Rav Yehudah would gather ten men and go and sit in his place. After seven days, [the deceased] appeared to him in a dream and said to him, "May your mind be at ease, for you have put my mind at ease." And they wrote that it stands to reason that since he troubled himself to gather ten men there, we can infer that he did so in order to pray there. Also, in the Baraita of Rabbi Eliezer, chapter 17, it is found: "When the Temple was destroyed, the sages instituted that mourners and bridegrooms should go to synagogues and study halls, etc." Nevertheless, in our Gemara it is proven that during the first week, a mourner does not leave the entrance of his house, even to go to the synagogue.

When praying in the mourner's house, they begin only from "Baruch She'amar" and do not recite the Songs [of Praise]. They based this on what was

[1] The text discusses prayer practices during shiva, the seven-day Jewish mourning period, specifically what prayers are omitted when prayer services are held in the house where mourners are sitting shiva.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4, Chapter 1 — The author is establishing the theological foundation for his discussion of prayer as a spiritual equivalent to Temple offerings. He specifically emphasizes how Torah study and recitation of prayer—particularly the incense offering prayer—creates the same metaphysical effects as the original Temple service through the spiritual connections between human actions below and their effects in the divine realms above. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The author is drawing on Zoharic concepts about how the Ketoret (incense offering) binds together all divine forms and serves as a particularly powerful connection between lower and higher worlds. The text alludes to the Zohar's teaching that the Ketoret has unique spiritual properties that other offerings lack. | Cf. Berachot 15a — The opening reference to the rabbinic teaching that 'Torah study serves in place of offerings' draws on the Talmudic principle that study of the sacrificial laws can spiritually substitute for the actual performance of sacrifices, which were no longer possible after the Temple's destruction. | Cf. Menachot 110a — The author is building on the Talmudic concept that Torah study about sacrifices has the same spiritual effect as performing the actual sacrifices, but expands this with kabbalistic explanations about how this works through the divine emanations.

[ii] The text is referencing a Talmudic source (Sanhedrin 44b) that provides the basis for gathering a minyan (prayer quorum) in a house of mourning.

[iii] Baruch She'amar is a blessing that opens the Pesukei D'zimra (Verses of Praise) section of the morning prayer service.

[iv] This refers to the Songs of Praise (Pesukei D'zimra) portion of the morning prayer service.

פ״ק מאי ולא קרב זה אל זה כל הלילה[i] בקשו מלאכי השרת לומר שירה א״ל הקב״ה מעשי ידי טובעים בים ואתם אומרים שירה לפני. אך בשבת אומרים ה׳ מלך ושירת ויושע. וא״א ג״כ ברכת כהנים דאבל ותשעה באב הוקשו זה לזה ובט׳ באב שחרית א״א אותו ומטעם זה א״א ג״כ תתקבל ואין נופלים שם על פניהם[ii] וא״א שם ועתה ולא אב הרחמן ווידוי. ברם במנחת ערב יום הכפורים אומרים וידוי משום דאבלות אתקש לחג דכתיב והפכתי חגיכם לאבל מלבד כי נפילת אפים בבית האבל אינו מן השם פן יתפש בדבריו במקום ריתחא[iii] ומטעם זה אין נפילת אפים בלילה אם לא סמוך לאשמורת כי הנפילה היא להכניע מדת הדין שהיא מדת הלילה ואם היו נופלין בלילה היו מגבירים כחה והוי כמקצץ בנטיעות ח״ו.[iv] אך סמוך ליום שמדת הדין מדת הרחמים ממשמשת לבא ולהתחבר אין כאן קצוץ. וכן נפילת אפים בבית האבל מגביר כח הדין והוי כמו קצוץ ח״ו. וכן אין נפילת

said[1] in Tractate Megillah, first chapter: What is meant by "and one did not approach the other all night"? The ministering angels sought to recite song [before God], but the Holy One, blessed be He, said to them, "My handiwork is drowning in the sea, and you wish to sing before Me?" However, on Sabbath, they do recite "Adonai Malach" and the Song of "Vayosha." 155R 160R

They also do not recite the Priestly Blessing,[2] for mourning and the Ninth of Av are compared to each other, and on the morning of the Ninth of Av, they do not recite it. For this reason, they also do not say "Titkabel" [in Kaddish], do not fall on their faces [for Tachanun], and do not say "Ve'atah," nor "Av HaRachaman," nor the confession. However, at the Mincha service on the eve of Yom Kippur, they do recite the confession, because mourning is compared to a festival, as it is written: "And I will turn your festivals into mourning." 165R 170R

Moreover, falling on one's face in the house of mourning is inappropriate, lest one's words be seized upon in a place of [divine] anger. For this reason, there is no falling on the face at night, unless it is near the morning watch, because the purpose of this prostration is to subdue the attribute of judgment,[3] which is the attribute of night. If they were to fall [in prayer] at night, they would strengthen its power, and it would be like "cutting the plantings"[4] [a metaphor for separating divine attributes], 175R 180R

[1] Throughout this passage, the author explains the halakhic reasoning behind various prayer customs in a house of mourning by referencing Talmudic sources and drawing analogies between mourning and other somber occasions like the Ninth of Av.

[2] The Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim) is omitted in a house of mourning following the comparison between mourning practices and those of the Ninth of Av (Tisha B'Av), when the blessing is also not recited in the morning service.

[3] In Jewish mysticism, God operates through various attributes or middot. The attribute of judgment (midat ha-din) represents strict justice without mercy, while the attribute of mercy (midat ha-rachamim) represents compassion. The text explains that certain prayer practices might inappropriately strengthen judgment at times when it's already dominant.

[4] The Hebrew term 'ketzitzat ha-neti'ot' (cutting the plantings) refers to the heretical act of Elisha ben Abuya (known as 'Acher') who metaphorically 'cut the plantings' of faith. In Kabbalistic thought, this represents improperly separating divine attributes, causing cosmic damage.

[i] This is a reference to Exodus 14:20, describing how the pillar of cloud separated the Egyptians from the Israelites at the Red Sea crossing, interpreted as angels refraining from singing while the Egyptians were drowning.

[ii] This refers to Tachanun, the supplication prayer during which worshippers traditionally bow their heads or, in some traditions, fall on their faces.

[iii] A kabbalistic term for a time of divine anger or judgment.

[iv] "Cutting the plantings" is a metaphorical expression from Jewish mysticism referring to separating the divine attributes in ways that damage their unity, considered a serious theological error.

אפים במקום שאין בו ספר תורה
שעל ידו התעוררות הרחמים
האמת כן הוא שבשעה שהצבור
נופלין על פניהם גם יחיד יכול
להתלות עמהם בביתו וצריך
כוונה גדולה פן ח״ו יתעורר
הדין ויסתתרו פני הרחמים.
וכן בבית האבל א״א ואני זאת
בריתי[i] וגו׳ לפי שאסור בדברי
תורה המשמחים לב והוא אסור
בכל שמחה וא״א שם הלל בראש
חדש דכתיב ביה נגילה ונשמחה
בו וסמכוהו הגאונים על הא
דתניא באבל רבתי דבעיר קטנה
אין שאלת שלום ביניהם וק״ו
שאין אומרים שם הלל. וכן עלינו
לשבח[ii] הוא שבח של שמחה ולכן
נהגו שלא לאומרו שם. וה״מ
בהלל דר״ח דמנהגא הוא אבל
בחנוכה יש אומרים שקורין הלל
ומברכין לפניי ולאחריו שכל
יחיד חייב לאומרו ובין ראש
השנה ליום הכפורים אומרים שם
אבינו מלכנו.[iii] [iv]

God forbid. But near daybreak, when the attribute of judgment [gives way as] the attribute of mercy approaches to join it, there is no such "cutting." Similarly, falling on one's face in a house of mourning strengthens the power of judgment and is like "cutting," God forbid. Likewise, there is no falling on the face in a place where there is no Torah scroll, through which mercy is aroused. The truth is that when the congregation falls on their faces, even an individual can join them in his house, but one needs great concentration lest, God forbid, judgment be aroused and the face of mercy be hidden.

And likewise, in a house of mourning, they do not say "And this is My covenant, etc.," because [the mourner] is forbidden to engage in words of Torah that gladden the heart, and he is forbidden all joy. They do not recite Hallel on the New Moon there, for it is written regarding it "we will rejoice and be glad on it." The Geonim based this on what was taught in the Great Mourning [tractate] that in a small town, people do not greet one another [during mourning], and all the more so, they do not recite Hallel there. Similarly, "Aleinu L'Shabeach" is a praise of joy, and therefore they customarily do not recite it there. This applies only to the Hallel of the New Moon, which is a custom, but on Chanukah, some say that they do read Hallel and recite the blessings before and after it, since every individual is obligated to recite it. And between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, they do recite "Avinu Malkeinu" there.

[i] This refers to Isaiah 59:21, which begins "And as for Me, this is My covenant with them..." This verse is recited after the Torah reading in the prayer service.

[ii] Aleinu L'Shabeach is a prayer recited at the end of each of the three daily prayer services.

[iii] Avinu Malkeinu (Our Father, Our King) is a prayer recited during the Ten Days of Repentance between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fourth Discourse, Part One — This section of Ma'avar Yabok explores the halakhic details of prayer services held in houses of mourning, providing the sources and mystical reasoning behind various customs, particularly which prayers are omitted and why. | Cf. Talmud Sanhedrin 44b — The author cites this Talmudic source as the basis for the custom of holding prayer services in the house of mourning, showing how prayer practices evolved from earlier comforting rituals. | Cf. Talmud Megillah 10b — This source is cited to explain why songs of praise are omitted in a house of mourning—just as joy is inappropriate when God's creatures are suffering, so too songs of praise are inappropriate in the presence of death and grief. | Cf. Baraita of Rabbi Eliezer, chapter 17 — The author uses this source to support the practice of communal prayer during mourning, while noting that later tradition modified this to keep mourners at home during the first week. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, sections on Tachanun and Nefilat Apayim — This passage connects to broader discussions within Ma'avar Yabok about the kabbalistic meaning of prayer postures, particularly how they interact with divine attributes of judgment and mercy.

פרק ב׳

Chapter 2

הנה מצאנו טעם לכל הדברים
המדלגים בבית האבל. אך
פליאה דעת ממני וגם יגעתי ולא
מצאתי מי שכתב שלא לומר שם
סדר פטום הקטרת. ונ״ל הדיוט
דטוב ויפה לאומרו ויועיל
לתקנת הנפטר ולנפשות החיים
הצריכים לרחמים ותנחומים
ואולי סרכייהו נקטי ואתו וילפי
מקלקלתא כאשר ראיתי בהרבה
קהלות הקדש שמבליעים סדר
זה שלא בנעימה וכתוב בר״מ
פ׳ פנחס דף רצ״ו ע״א על
פסוק וטחנו ברחים מהכא מאן
דאפיק מלין דאורייתא צריך
למטחן להו בשנים ולאפקא
מלין שלמין. ואחרנין דאינון
שטיין ואכלין מלין בהבלעה
ולא טחנין לון בטחנין דילהון
ובשינהון כתיב בהו הבשר
עודנו בין שניהם[i] דאינון מגזעא
דמאן דאמר הלעיטני נא. ואם
בדברי תורה כך כל שכן בתפלה
דרחמי היא וכ״ש וק״ו בסדר
הקטרת המקשר צורות קדושות
בהבלו ונאמר בו אם חסר אחת
מכל סממניה חייב מיתה[ii] ויש
הרבה מבני הקהל שא״א אותו

Now we have found reasons for all the things that are skipped in a house of mourning. But it is a wonder to me, and though I have toiled, I have not found anyone who wrote that one should not recite there the order of the Preparation of the Incense. And it seems to me, humble as I am, that it is good and fitting to recite it, as it will benefit the correction of the departed soul and the souls of the living who need mercy and consolation. Perhaps they cling to their custom and have learned from corrupted practices,[1] as I have seen in many holy communities where they swallow this order [of pray[2]er] unpleasantly. It is written in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas, page 296a,[A] regarding the verse "and ground it in mills," that from here we learn that one who brings forth words of Torah must grind them with his teeth and produce complete words. And others who are fools eat words by swallowing them without grinding them with their mills and teeth—about them it is written, "the meat was still between their teeth," for they are of the stock of those who said, "feed me, please." And if this applies to words of Torah, how much more so to prayer, which is [a plea for] mercy, and all the more so to the order of the Incense, which binds together holy forms with its breath,[3] and concerning which it is said that if one component of all its ingredients is missing, one is liable to death. There

5R 10R 15R 20R 25R

[A] Or: "It is written in Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd) section of the Zohar, Parashat Pinchas, folio 296a" — The abbreviation 'R"M' specifically refers to 'Ra'aya Mehemna' which is a particular section within the Zohar. Adding this clarification helps readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic literature understand the source being cited.

[1] The phrase 'סרכייהו נקטי ואתו וילפי מקלקלתא' uses legal terminology. 'Sirkheihu' refers to established precedent or custom, while 'kalkalata' refers to corruption or degradation, suggesting the author believes the practice of omitting the Ketoret in houses of mourning arose from misguided precedents.

[2] The author uses a play on words with 'swallowing' (מבליעים) prayers, which connects to his subsequent citation about properly 'grinding' and not 'swallowing' words of Torah. This metaphor criticizes hasty, mumbled recitation without proper articulation.

[3] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the Ketoret prayer creates mystical unifications in the upper worlds through the breath used to pronounce the words, affecting cosmic reality. This is why proper articulation is especially important for this prayer.

[i] This combines two biblical references: the grinding of manna in mills (Numbers 11:8) and "the meat was still between their teeth" (Numbers 11:33), creating a metaphor for improperly articulated prayers.

[ii] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Keritot 6a) that if the Temple incense was prepared without any of its required ingredients, the preparer was liable to the death penalty. The author applies this strictness to the proper recitation of the prayer.

כלל אפי׳ בהלעטה ואי איישר
חילי אבטליניה למנהג הרע
הזה ואולי זה אחד מתחבולות
המנגד דהשתא בעקבות משיחא
חוצפא יסגא[i] אמסר עלמא
בידא דטפשאי אשר בקטרוגם
מפתים בני אדם לעזוב ארחות
יושר וללכת בדרכי חשך הן הן
המלפתים ארחות דרכם כדרך
שכל דבר מתגבר נגד הפכו.
וקובלנא גדולה אית לי על
החזנים שהרגילו עצמם לקרא
סדר זה עראי ואחריהם כל
הקהל ימשוך. וכל מי שדבריו
נשמעים חובה להשתדל בכל עוז
שהחזן יאמר סדר זה לפני התיבה
בקול מלה במלה כדרך שאומר
היוצר והעמידה בקול ולא יפנה
עצמו אנה ואנה בעת קריאתו
ובזה כל אחד מהקהל יהיו
לאחדים עמו כי עתה בעונותינו
אין לנו דבר מסוגל לבטל כל
נגע וכל פגע רע כהזכרת מעשה
הקטרת בבתי כנסיות בכוונת
הלב וכן כל אחד בביתו. ובחרתי
ללקוט שושנים מדברי הר״ש בן
יוחאי בס׳ הזהר והתקונים ור״מ
ומדרש שיר השירים ומתרגום
יונתן שמתוכם יראה המעיין
כי כנים דברי. ומובטחני בזה
שכל הלומד ע״מ לעשות יאזור
כגבר חלציו מן היום הזה והלאה
להיות זהיר וזריז באמירת סדר
זה פעמים בכל יום בכל כחו
וכוונתו וממנו יראו אחרים וכן
יעשו והמשרה הזאת על הש״צ
וראשי כנסיות שבכל עיר ופלך
ובראשם עטרות החכמים ישמרם
ה׳ ויחיו לנצח. פוקו נא וחזו

are many members of the congregation who do not say it at all, even by swallowing it, and if I had the strength, I would abolish this evil custom.[A] Perhaps this is one of the schemes of the adversary, for now, in the footsteps of the Messiah, insolence will increase[B] and the world has been delivered into the hands of fools, who through their accusations entice people to abandon the paths of uprightness and walk in the ways of darkness—they are the ones who twist the paths of their way, as everything grows stronger against its opposite.

And I have a great complaint against the cantors who have accustomed themselves to recite this order casually, and the entire congregation follows them. And it is the duty of anyone whose words are heeded to strive with all might that the cantor should recite this order before the ark aloud, word by word, just as he recites the Yotzer [prayer] and the Amidah aloud, and he should not turn himself here and there during its recitation. In this way, each member of the congregation will be united with him, for now, in our sins, we have nothing as effective for nullifying every plague and every evil affliction as the mention of the Incense service in synagogues with the intention of the heart, and so too by each person in his home.

I have chosen to gather roses from the words of Rabbi Shimon ben Yochai in the book of the Zohar and the Tikkunim and Ra'aya Mehemna, and from the Midrash Shir HaShirim and from the Targum Yonatan, from which the reader will see that my words are true. And I am confident in this, that anyone who learns in order to practice will gird his loins like a man from this day forward to be careful and diligent in reciting this order twice every day with all his strength and intention, and from him others will see and do likewise. And this responsibility rests upon the prayer leader and the heads of congregations in every city and district, and at their head, the crown of the sages—may God protect them

[A] Or: "and if my authority were sufficient, I would abolish this evil custom" — The Aramaic phrase 'איישר חילי' can refer not just to physical strength but to authority or power to enforce a ruling, which better fits the context of a rabbi discussing ritual practice.

[B] Or: "for now, in the pre-messianic era, insolence has increased" — The phrase 'in the footsteps of the Messiah' (ikvot meshicha) is a rabbinic term for the period preceding the messianic age, characterized by various spiritual and social challenges. This translation better conveys the eschatological context.

[i] This is a reference to Talmudic teachings (Sotah 49b) about the signs of the pre-messianic era, which include increased insolence and a decline in religious observance.

במדרש הנעלם דף ק״א מעשה
ר׳ אחא כד אזיל לכפר טרשא
ובטיל מותנא באמירת פטום
הקטרת וסדר קרבנות עמו ג׳
פעמים בכל ד׳ פנות העיר וכן
אמרו בבתי הנוטים למות עם
פסוקי ויאמר משה אל אהרן
קח את המחתה וגו׳ ויעמוד
בין המתים וגו׳ ובזה אתבטיל
מותנא[i] ושם בדף ק׳ אמר רבי
ברוספדאי האי מאן דמדכר
בפומיה בבתי כנסיות ובבתי
מדרשות ענייא דקרבניא
ותקרובתא ויכוין בהו ברית
כרותה הוא דאינון מלאכיא
דמדכרין חוביה לאבאשא ליה
דלא יכלין למעבד ליה אלא
טיבו. עוד שם ע״ב אמר ר׳
פנחס זמנא חדא הוינא אזיל
בארחא וערעית ביה באליהו
אמינא ליה לימא לי מר מלה
דמעלייא לברייתא. א״ל קיים
גזר קב״ה ואתקין כל אלין
מלאכיא דממנן לאדכרא חוביה
דבר נש די בעדנא די דכרון
בני אנשא קורבניא דמני משה
אתגזר וכרוזא עבר על כל חילא
דשמיא דאי יעלון בנוהי בארעא
בבתי כנסיות ובבתי מדרשות
וימרון ברעות נפשא ולבא
ענייא דקטרת בוסמין דהוו ליה
לישראל דיתבטל מותנא מיניהו
ע״כ. ובפ׳ ויקרא אמר כל מאן
דאסתכל וקרי בעובדא דקטרת
בכל יומא אשתזיב מכל מלין
דחרשייא ומכל פגעין בישין
ומהרהורין בישין ומדינא בישא
וממותנא ולא איתזק כל ההוא
יומא ולא יכיל סטרא אחרא
לשלטא ביה ובלבד דיכוין ביה.
והרב בעל סדר היום כתב וזה
לשונו החושש עליו ועל נפשו

and may they live forever.

Go forth, please, and see in the Midrash HaNe'elam, page 101, the story of Rabbi Acha when he went to Kfar Tarsha and stopped a plague by reciting the Preparation of the Incense and the Order of Sacrifices with it three times at all four corners of the city. And they also said it in the houses of those who were inclined toward death, along with the verses "And Moses said to Aaron, 'Take the censer,'" etc., "and he stood between the dead," etc., and thereby the plague was stopped. And there on page 100, Rabbi Chrospedai said: "Whoever mentions with his mouth in synagogues and study houses the matter of sacrifices and offerings and focuses his intention on them—there is a covenant that those angels who mention his sins to harm him will not be able to do anything to him except good."[1] Furthermore, it says there, Rabbi Pinchas said: "Once I was going on the road and encountered Elijah. I said to him, 'Please tell me, sir, something excellent for people.' He said to me, 'The Holy One, blessed be He, has decreed and established, and all those angels appointed to mention the sins of a person have entered before Him. At the time when people mention the sacrifices that Moses commanded, it has been decreed and a proclamation has gone out to all the heavenly hosts that if His children enter on earth into synagogues and study houses and say with the desire of their soul and heart the matter of the incense of spices that Israel had, the plague will be stopped from among them.'"

And in Parashat Vayikra it says: "Anyone who contemplates and reads the work of the incense every day will be saved from all matters of sorcery and from all evil afflictions and from evil thoughts and from evil judgment and from plague, and he will not be harmed all that day, and the Other Side will not be able to rule over him—provided that he focuses his intention on it." And the Rabbi, author of Seder HaYom, wrote, and this is his language: "One who is concerned about himself and his soul

70R 75R 80R 85R 90R 95R 100R 105R

[1] According to kabbalistic belief, the recitation of passages about Temple sacrifices, especially the Ketoret, transforms spiritual accusers into defenders, literally converting negative spiritual energy into positive force.

[i] This references the biblical account in Numbers 17:11-13 where Aaron's offering of incense stopped a plague, establishing the precedent for the Ketoret's protective power.

ראוי להשתדל בכל עוז בענין הזה ולכתוב כל ענין הקטרת בקלף כשר בכתיבה אשורית ולקרות אותו פעם אחת בבקר ובערב בכוונה גדולה ואני ערב. ואח״כ יאמר אביי הוה מסדר וכו׳ עכ״ל.[i]

should strive with all might in this matter and write the entire matter of the incense on kosher parchment in Assyrian script and read it once in the morning and evening with great intention, and I guarantee it." And afterward he should say, "Abaye would arrange," etc. End of quote.

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

הנה בדבר נקל יוכל האדם להנצל מכמה פגעים רעים. ובזהר פרשת ויקהל דף רי״ט ע״א[ii] אמרו סימנא דא אתמסר בידנא די בכל אתר דקאמרו בכוונה ורעותא דלבא עובדא דקטרת דלא שלטא מותנא בההוא אתר ולא אתזק. עוד כתב ת״ח מאן דדינא רדיף בתריה אצטריך להאי קטרת ולאתבא קמי מריה והא סיועא איהו לאסתלקא דינין מיניה ובהא ודאי מסתלקין מיניה אי הוא רגיל בהאי לאדכרא תרין זמנין ביומא בצפרא וברמשא ודא הוא קיומא דעלמא לתתא וקיומא דעלמא לעילא בההוא אתר דלא אדכר בכל יומא עובדא דקטרת דינין דלעילא שריין ביה ואע״ג דצלותא איהי מעלי׳א מכלא עובדא דקטרת הוא חביב ויקיר קמיה דקודשא

Thus with a simple thing, a person can be saved from many evil occurrences.[1] And in the Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel, page 219a, they said: "This sign has been transmitted to us: in any place where people recite with intention and desire of the heart the matter of the incense, no plague will have power in that place, nor will it be harmed." It is further written: "Come and see, one who is pursued by judgment needs this incense, and to return before his Master, for it is an aid to remove judgments from him. And with this, judgments are certainly removed from him if he is accustomed to mentioning it twice daily, in the morning and in the evening. This is the sustenance of the world below and the sustenance of the world above. In a place where the matter of the incense is not mentioned daily, the judgments from above rest upon it. And although prayer is superior to all, the act of the incense is beloved and precious before the Holy One, blessed be He. Prayer is a rectification to correct what is needed; incense does more than rectification—it binds knots, creates greater illumination than anything else, re-

[1] The Hebrew 'davar nakel' (literally 'an easy thing') refers to the seemingly simple act of reciting the incense formula, which the author emphasizes is an accessible practice that nonetheless has powerful protective effects.

[i] Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna (Parashat Pinchas) — The author cites this passage to criticize those who hastily recite prayers without proper articulation, arguing that if clear pronunciation is required for Torah study, it is even more necessary for prayer, especially the Ketoret which has mystical significance. | Cf. Midrash HaNe'elam (Hidden Midrash) — The author uses these stories to demonstrate the practical efficacy of the Ketoret recitation for protection against plagues and spiritual harm, reinforcing his argument that it should be recited even in houses of mourning. | Cf. Seder HaYom — The author cites this later halakhic work to demonstrate that the protective power of the Ketoret was recognized by authorities beyond the Zohar, and to provide practical guidance for those who wish to benefit from its recitation. | Cf. Numbers 17:11-13 — The biblical source for the power of the Ketoret to stop plagues, which the author references to establish the ancient precedent for this practice and to connect the synagogue recitation to the original Temple ritual.

[ii] The author cites specific page references from the Zohar, demonstrating his scholarly approach and inviting readers to verify his sources. This detailed citation practice is characteristic of rabbinic scholarship.

בריך הוא. צלותא איהו תקונא
לאתקנא מה דאצריך קטרת
עביד יתיר מתקון וקשיר קשרין
ועביד נהירו יתיר מכלא ואעבר
זוהמא ואי זכי משכנא כלא
אתנהר ואתתקן ואתקשר כחדא.
אח״כ כתב כי מעשה הקטרת
קודם לזמירות הבקר. וז״ל
קטרת איהו קדמאה תדיר קודם
לכלא ובג״כ עובדא דקטרת
אצטריך לאקדמא צלותא
בשירין ותושבחן לאעברא זוהמא
ולאתדכאה קודשא ולבתר שירין
ותושבחן וצלותין כלא כדאמרן.
עוד בפ׳ תרומה שם זירז על זה
וז״ל מפומא דאליהו כך אתמר
במתיבתא עילאה דרקיעא[i] בכל
אתר דמדכרין עובדא דקטרת
תרין זמנין ביומא מותנא ומרעין
בישין אתבטלו מבינייהו ואתרא
דלא מדכרי עובדא דקטרת תרין
זמנין ביומא מותנא ומרעין בישין
אשתכחו בינייהו ואית מארה
בעובדייהו ואש דגהינם שליט
עלייהו בג״ד אצטריך לכל ב״נ
לאזהרא ביה בכל יומא ות״ח
אי הוו ידעי בני נשא עובדא
דקטרת כמה יקירא ועילאה
איהו הוו מעיילי כל מלה ומלה
כמו עטרה דדהבא על רישייהו
ות״ח מה כתיב ועשית מזבח
מקטר קטרת והא לא דבחין ביה
אלא רזא איהו דמיניה ערקין כל
שדין רוחין ולילין ולית לון רשו
למעבד שום ביש כד״א ויתן את
הקטרת ויכפר על העם. ומתוכו
למדנו היות בקריאת הקטרת
חמש תועליות הא׳ ביטול המגפה
והחולאים. ב׳ מציל מגלות. ג׳
בעבורו הברכה מצויה במעשה
ידי אדם והצלחה בענייניו. ד׳
מציל מדינה של גהינם. ה׳ בטול
החצונים והקליפות. ובזהר
שיר השירים האריכו עוד בענין

moves impurity, and if the Tabernacle merits, everything becomes illuminated, rectified, and bound together." Afterward, it is written that the act of 25R
the incense precedes the morning hymns. In these words: "The incense is always first before everything, and because of this, the act of the incense needs to precede prayer with songs and praises to remove impurity and to purify holiness; and afterward songs, 30R
praises, and prayers—all as we have said." Furthermore, in Parashat Terumah, he urged about this, saying: "From the mouth of Elijah, thus it was said in the supernal heavenly academy: In every place where people mention the act of the incense twice 35R
daily, plagues and evil diseases are nullified from among them. And in a place where they do not mention the act of the incense twice daily, plagues and evil diseases are found among them, and there is a curse in their actions, and the fire of Gehenna 40R
rules over them. Therefore, it is necessary for every person to be careful about this every day. And come and see, if people knew how precious and lofty the act of the incense is, they would place every word of it like a crown of gold upon their heads. And 45R
come and see what is written: 'And you shall make an altar for burning incense'—and indeed they do not sacrifice upon it, but it is a mystery, for from it flee all demons, spirits, and night spirits, and they have no permission to do any evil, as it is said: 'And 50R
he put on the incense and made atonement for the people.'"

From this we learn that there are five benefits in reciting the incense: 1) Nullification of plague and diseases; 2) Salvation from exile; 3) Because of it, 55R
blessing is found in a person's handiwork and success in his affairs; 4) Salvation from the judgment of Gehenna; 5) Nullification of external forces and negative entities. And in the Zohar on the Song of Songs, they elaborated further on this matter, 60R
saying: "Incense—anyone who smelled that smoke when the column of that smoke ascended would be purified with clarity and illumination, with joy and willingness to serve his Master, for it removed from him the filth and impurity of the evil inclination, 65R
and he would have only one heart toward his Fa-

[i]The text attributes this teaching to Elijah the Prophet as spoken in the 'heavenly academy,' giving it the highest possible authority. In mystical literature, teachings ascribed to Elijah often represent revelations of deep mysteries.

הזה וז״ל קטרת כל מאן דארח
בההוא תננא כד סליק עמודא
דההוא מעלה עשן הוה מברר
70 להו בברירו ונהירו בחדוה
ורעותא למפלח למריה דאעבר
מיניה טנופא וזוהמא דיצה״ר
ולא הוה ליה אלא לבא חדא
לקבל אבוהי דבשמיא בגין
75 דקטרת תבירו דיצה״ר איהו
בכל סטרין ולית לן מלה בעלמא
דמתבר ליה לס״א בר מקטרת
דהא לית חדוה וחביבו קמיה
קב״ה בקטרת וקיימא לבטלא
80 חרשין ומלין בישין מביתא ריחא
ועשבא דקטרת דעבדי בני נשא
להההוא עובדא דקא מבטל כ״ש
קטרת מלה דא אתגזר ואתקיימא
קמיה קב״ה דכל מאן דיסתכל
85 וקרי בכל יומא עובדא דקטרת
אשתזיב מכל אלין חרשין ואית
ליה חולקא בעלמא דין ובעלמא
דאתי ואסתלק מותנא מיניה
ומעלמא בנזכר למעלה הנה כי
90 זולת הסגולות הקודמות עוד יש
לו סגולות אחרות[i] הא׳ בטול
הכשפים. הב׳ בטול הרהורים
רעים. הג׳ נוחל חלק העוה״ז
וחלק העוה״ב. הד׳ מסלק הדין
95 מעליו כי סודו גדול בפנימיות
וקטרת לשון קשר המקשר
אותיות שם בן ד׳ יחד[ii] בסוד
העשן המסתלק מעלה מעלה
בחוטמא ושכיך רוגזא ומיחד

ther in Heaven,[1] because the incense breaks the evil inclination in all directions. And we have nothing in the world that breaks the Other Side except for incense, for there is no joy and love before the Holy 70R
One, blessed be He, like the incense. And it stands to nullify sorceries and evil things from the house. The scent and herb of incense that people make for this purpose nullifies [evil]—how much more so the incense itself! This matter has been decreed and es- 75R
tablished before the Holy One, blessed be He, that whoever contemplates and recites daily the matter of the incense will be saved from all these sorceries, and will have a portion in this world and in the World to Come, and plague will be removed from him and 80R
from the world," as mentioned above.

Behold, apart from the previous special properties, it has other special properties: 1) Nullification of sorceries; 2) Nullification of evil thoughts; 3) Inheriting a portion in this world and in the World 85R
to Come; 4) Removing judgment from oneself, for its secret is great in the inner dimension. And "ketoret" (incense) is derived from the language of "kesher" (binding),[2] binding the letters of the four-letter Name together, through the secret of the smoke 90R
that ascends higher and higher into the nostrils, calming anger,[3] and uniting the bridegroom with his bride. And all the chariots—holy forces that receive along with forces that bestow—all become bound and united through the incense. They further 95R
said that in all the sacrifices, there was a portion for the external forces, like the limbs and fats that are consumed throughout the night, and the smoke would bend toward the north.[4] However, the incense

[1] This metaphor of 'one heart' (liba chada) is significant, suggesting that the incense offering/recitation creates a singular focus and undivided devotion, removing the 'divided heart' caused by the evil inclination.

[2] This etymological interpretation connecting 'ketoret' (קטרת) with 'kesher' (קשר) is central to the kabbalistic understanding of incense as creating cosmic unifications and bindings of divine forces.

[3] The Hebrew 'v'shakhikh rogza' describes how the smoke of the incense metaphysically calms divine anger or judgment. This draws on the anthropomorphic biblical imagery of God's nostrils as the seat of divine anger (as in 'the anger of the Lord was kindled').

[4] In kabbalistic cosmology, the north direction is associated with the forces of judgment and impurity. This description of regular sacrifice smoke bending northward symbolizes that a portion of their power goes to these forces, unlike the incense which is entirely directed upward to God.

[i] This passage systematically lists ten distinct benefits or special properties (segulot) of the incense offering or recitation, showing the author's effort to organize and categorize the spiritual benefits described in various Zoharic passages.

[ii] The author provides an etymological interpretation connecting 'ketoret' (incense) with 'kesher' (bond/tie), revealing the kabbalistic understanding that the incense ritual functions to unify the four letters of the divine name (the Tetragrammaton).

חתן עם כלתו[i] וכל המרכבות
כחות קדושים מקבלים עם
כחות משפיעים כלם נקשרים
ומתייחדים ע״י הקטרת. עוד
אמרו שבכל הקרבנות היה חלק
לחצונים כעין אברים ופדרים
דמתאכלין כל הלילה והעשן
היה נעקם לצד צפון[ii] אמנם
הקטרת היה כלו לגבוה. ועולה
במקום הקדש ומיחד ומקשר כל
המדרגות מנקודה ראשונה עד
האחרונה:[iii]

was entirely for the Most High. And it ascends to the holy place and unifies and binds all levels from the first point to the last.[1] 100R

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

הלא ידענו כי עקר הרצוי
ביום האדיר[iv] היה בקטרת
דקה מן הדקה[v] העולה לבסם
כח הדינים שבבינה ומיחדה

We know that the primary purpose on the awesome day[A] [Yom Kippur] was through the incense, ground exceptionally fine,[B] which ascends to sweeten the powers of judgment in Binah and unite it with

[A] Or: "on the great day" — While 'awesome day' captures the reverence for Yom Kippur, 'great day' is a more literal translation of 'yom ha'adir' and might be preferred in contexts emphasizing the day's significance rather than its awe-inspiring nature.

[B] Or: "incense of the finest grinding" — The phrase 'dakah min ha-dakah' is a superlative

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the sefirot (divine emanations), from Keter (Crown, the highest point) to Malkhut (Kingdom, the lowest point), suggesting that the incense creates unification throughout the entire divine structure.

[i] This is a reference to the mystical unification of divine masculine and feminine aspects, referred to as 'bridegroom' and 'bride' in kabbalistic literature. This matrimonial imagery for divine union is central to kabbalistic theology, particularly in the Zohar.

[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the north direction is associated with the forces of judgment and impurity. The smoke of regular sacrifices bending northward symbolizes that a portion of their power goes to sustain even the negative forces, while the incense smoke rises straight up, giving nothing to these forces.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel 219a — This Zohar passage is directly quoted to establish the central argument that reciting the incense formula with proper intention protects from plague and disease. The author uses this as a foundational text for the entire section on incense. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This passage attributes teachings about incense to Elijah the Prophet as transmitted in the heavenly academy, giving divine authority to the practice of reciting the incense formula twice daily for protection from plagues. | Cf. Exodus 30:1 — This biblical verse is referenced to establish the divine origin of the incense altar, supporting the argument that the incense ritual has special cosmic significance. | Cf. Numbers 17:12-13 — This alludes to Aaron stopping a plague with incense, a central biblical proof text for the protective power of incense against disease and death. | Cf. Zohar on Song of Songs — This reference expands on the transformative spiritual effects of incense, emphasizing how it purifies the person from the evil inclination and creates unity of heart in divine service. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:6 — The description of the "column of smoke ascending" echoes the biblical verse "Who is this coming up from the wilderness like columns of smoke, perfumed with myrrh and frankincense..." which in Jewish mystical tradition is associated with the soul's ascent and the unification of divine forces.

[iv] This refers to Yom Kippur, often called 'the awesome day' or 'the mighty day' in rabbinic literature.

[v] This refers to the special preparation of incense for Yom Kippur, which according to Talmudic tradition (Keritot 6a) was ground exceptionally fine beyond the normal grinding for regular daily incense.

בחכמה שהיא שמן כתית ולכן
היה לפני ולפנים[i] והקטרת הלז
היה מתקן וממתק גם רמז דם
הפר והשעיר במקורם העליון
מכין הדם ההוא שיהיו ראויים
להזות אותם לפני ולפנים.
על כן היו ממרסן בהם על
הרובד הרביעי שבעזרה[ii] בעת
עשיית הקטרת לפני ולפנים
כנדרש בתקוני יוה״כ ובכחו
הדם נעשה חלב. הנה כמה רב
גובריה בבסום הדין. ובו אחד
עשר סממנים העשרה רומזים
לעשר ספירות והחלבנה רמזה
לסוד שרש החצונים המשורשים
בקדש[iii] כנדרש אצלנו על פ׳
ראש פתנים אכזר. פירוש א״ך
ז״ר[iv] ומה טעם משום דהלא הוא
כמוס עמדי חתום באוצרותי
ליום אשר לי נקם ושלם וגו׳
בנזכר למעלה וזהו בוונת
אמרם רשעים בחייהם קרויים
מתים[v] וכבר איפסיקא הלכתא
כר׳ עקיבא מוליכין הגוף אצל
הראש[vi] כי בבסום שרשם למעלה
יתחלש כח התפשטותם למטה
כי הדין הוא הפך הרחמים
והתגברות שרש הרחמים למעלה

Chokhmah, which is like beaten oil. This is why it was offered in the Holy of Holies. This incense would rectify and sweeten even the symbolic blood of the bull and goat at their supernal source, preparing that blood to be worthy of sprinkling before the innermost sanctuary. Therefore, they would stir them on the fourth tier of the Temple courtyard during the preparation of the incense for the Holy of Holies, as required in the Yom Kippur rituals, and through its power, the blood was transformed into fat. Behold how great is its power in sweetening judgment.[A]

The incense contained eleven ingredients: ten corresponding to the ten sefirot,[1] while the galbanum symbolized the root of the external forces[2] [negative spiritual entities] that are rooted in holiness, as we have explained regarding the verse "the cruel venom of serpents." This means "only foreign," and the reason is "for this is hidden with Me, sealed in My treasuries until the day of vengeance and recompense," as mentioned above. This is the meaning of the saying, "The wicked are called dead even in their lifetime," and the law has been decided according to Rabbi Akiva that "the body is brought to the head." For when their root above is sweetened, their power of expansion below is weakened, since judgment is the opposite of mercy. When the root of mercy grows stronger

construction in Hebrew indicating the finest possible grinding. This alternate translation preserves the superlative quality while using a more compact phrasing.

[A] Or: "in mitigating severity" — While 'sweetening judgment' is the standard kabbalistic terminology, 'mitigating severity' might be clearer for readers less familiar with kabbalistic concepts, as it conveys the idea of tempering harshness or strictness.

[1] The sefirot are the ten divine emanations or attributes through which God interacts with the world according to Kabbalah. The author is establishing a correspondence between the physical ingredients of the incense and these cosmic structures.

[2] In Kabbalah, 'ha-chitzonim' (the external ones) refers to negative spiritual forces or entities that exist outside the realm of holiness, often understood as the origin of evil and impurity.

[i] A technical term referring to the Holy of Holies, the innermost sanctuary of the Temple that the High Priest entered only on Yom Kippur.

[ii] Refers to a specific location in the Temple courtyard where ritual preparations took place.

[iii] The author presents a kabbalistic interpretation of galbanum, which had a foul smell yet was included in the sacred incense. This paradox is interpreted as symbolizing how even negative forces have their ultimate source in holiness.

[iv] A kabbalistic word play where the letters of 'achzar' (cruel) are rearranged to spell 'ach zar' (only foreign/strange), suggesting that evil is merely a foreign element that can be reintegrated.

[v] A Talmudic dictum (Berakhot 18b) stating that the wicked are considered dead even while alive, because they are spiritually disconnected.

[vi] This refers to a halakhic ruling about burial practices, used here metaphorically to illustrate how lower forces (the body) must be brought into alignment with higher forces (the head).

מתהדר ומתפשט כחם למטה
אבל הדין במתוק שרשו יתקבצו
בחותיו התחתונות למעלה ולא
יפעלו עוד. וא״כ אחד עשר
סממנים ירמזו לי׳ ספירות
עם בחינת המלכות על כסאה
בבחינתה למטה בסוד רגליה
יורדות.[i] וכמו שבטורי״אקה
הגדולה[ii] הנעשית מדברים רבים
ישימו בה בשר האפעה ואז
היא מועילה מאד להרבה מיני
חולאים כשיקחוה בזמנה ועל
פי עצת רופא כי אם לא יקחוה
בזמנה ובתנאיה כתב הרמב״ם
ז״ל כי לפעמים ממיתה וכן אירע
לבני אהרן ולעדת קרח בהקטרת
כן החלבנה היתה בקטרת שהיא
טורייקא מועלת בפלא ובסגולה
גדולה לנגד המתחדש מצד
גרמת הפירוד והפגם בעליונים
ובתחתונים והוא מחזר ומקשר
ומיפה הכחות כלם וכוונת
שימת החלבנה בה לקשר באותם
הסממנים הטובים החומר הרע
הזה הוא שטן הוא יצה״ר לקשרו
ולכבשו שם. וברא״מ פ׳ פנחס דף
רצ״ד ע״א אמר על קטרת כד
סליק באף נקרא קטרת הה״ד
ישימו קטורה באפך ולית דבטיל
מותנא מעלמא בקטרת דאיהו

above, its power expands below, but when judgment is sweetened at its root, its lower powers gather upward and no longer act. 35R

Thus, the eleven ingredients allude to the ten sefirot along with the aspect of Malkhut on its throne, in its aspect below, in the mystery of "her feet descend."[A] Just as in the great theriac[1] [medicinal compound] made from many ingredients, they place in it viper's flesh, and then it becomes extremely beneficial for many types of illnesses when taken at the proper time and according to a physician's advice. But if not taken at the proper time and under the right conditions, Maimonides of blessed memory wrote that it sometimes kills, as happened to the sons of Aaron and to Korah's assembly with their incense. Similarly, galbanum was included in the incense, which is like a wonderfully effective theriac with great protective power against the damage caused by separation and blemish in the upper and lower realms. It circulates, binds, and beautifies all the forces, and the purpose of placing galbanum in it was to bind this evil substance—which is Satan, which is the evil inclination[2]—with those good ingredients, to bind and subdue it there. 40R 45R 50R 55R

In Ra'aya Mehemna [a section of the Zohar], Parashat Pinchas, page 294a, it says about the incense: "When it ascends through the nose, it is called 'ketoret,' as it is written, 'They shall put incense in Your nostrils.'[3] Nothing eliminates plague 60R

[A] Or: "Thus, the eleven ingredients symbolize the ten sefirot plus Malkhut in its lower manifestation, as in the esoteric teaching that "her feet descend."" — This alternate translation uses more technical kabbalistic terminology ('symbolize' instead of 'allude to' and 'manifestation' instead of 'aspect') which might be preferred in a more scholarly translation aimed at readers familiar with kabbalistic concepts.

[1] The author uses theriac, an ancient medicinal compound that paradoxically contained poison (viper's flesh) as an ingredient, as a metaphor for how the sacred incense incorporates the foul-smelling galbanum. This illustrates the kabbalistic principle that even negative elements can be transformed into positive forces when properly integrated.

[2] This formulation equates Satan (the cosmic adversary) with the evil inclination (yetzer hara), suggesting they are different manifestations of the same negative force that can be bound and subdued through proper ritual.

[3] This references Deuteronomy 33:10, which in its original context refers to the Levitical priests' role in offering incense. The Zohar reinterprets this verse to explain the etymology and function of the incense (ketoret).

[i] Alludes to Proverbs 5:5, 'Her feet go down to death,' which in Kabbalah refers to how Malkhut (the lowest sefirah) extends downward into the lower realms.

[ii] Theriac was a complex medicinal compound containing dozens of ingredients, including viper's flesh, used from ancient times through the Renaissance as an antidote against poisons and various diseases.

קשורא דדינא ברחמי על דרך
ריח ניחוחי דתרגומו דקשר
קטורו עוד אמר בוצינא קדישא
דבתר צלותא איהי כקרבנא
מאן דיימא פטום הקטרת בתר
תהלה לדוד בטיל מותנא מביתא.
הנה כי טוב להקדימו עם סדר
הקרבנות קודם הזמירות מן
הטעם שכתב בפ׳ ויקהל כנזכר
וגם אחר קדושת ובא לציון
שתרגום הקדושה הוא לבטל
הדמות שראה נבוכדנצר[i] הרומז
קומת החצונים כלם וכבר נמחץ
בראשו כי נבוכדנצר מן אנשא
טריד ועתיד ללקות מכה רבה
על רגליו באבן די לא בידין
ואז יכלו ויספו כנראה מפסוקי
דניאל. על כן נאות לומר אחר
קדושת ובא לציון פטום הקטרת
כמ״ש רעיא מהימנא.[ii] ואני
הנהגתי עצמי לאומרו אחר פ׳
התמיד כסדר הכתוב בסדורים
שלנו ופעם אחרת עם הקהל
וזה כמו שסדור במעמדות. אין
ספק שעל פי הדברים האלה טוב
ויפה ונעים לאומרו בבית האבל
לבטל מותנא מן ביתיה אפי׳ לא
יועיל שם לכמה שאר דברים
להיות כי נסתם תפלתו יען אין
השכינה שורה מתוך עצבות
ובפרט שעל הרוב סבת העצבות
הוא על אבוד הגוף שהוא חלק
החצוני דנחית לעפרא. בגין
דיתמחי יצה״ר דבגויה. וגם
נפש הנפטר נהנה ודאי מההבל
אשר יעלה בהזכרת כח סממנים

from the world like incense, which binds judgment with mercy, as indicated by the phrase 'pleasing fragrance,' which is translated as 'a bound offering.'" 65R
The holy luminary further said: "After prayer, it is like a sacrifice. Whoever recites Pitum HaKetoret after Ashrei [Psalm 145] eliminates plague from the house."

Therefore, it is good to recite it with the order of sacrifices before the morning psalms, for the reason written in Parashat Vayakhel, as mentioned above. It is also appropriate after the Kedushah of U'va L'Tzion, since the translation of the Kedushah serves to nullify the image seen by Nebuchadnezzar,[1] which symbolizes the entire structure of the external forces. Nebuchadnezzar has already been struck in his head, for "Nebuchadnezzar was driven from humanity," and he will be severely stricken on his feet by "a stone not cut by hands," and then they will be completely destroyed, as appears from the verses in Daniel. Therefore, it is fitting to recite Pitum HaKetoret after the Kedushah of U'va L'Tzion, as stated in Ra'aya Mehemna. I have accustomed myself to recite it after the passage about the daily offering, as arranged in our prayer books, and again with the congregation, as arranged in the Ma'amadot prayers. 70R 75R 80R 85R

There is no doubt that according to these principles, it is good, fitting, and pleasant to recite it in a house of mourning to eliminate plague from the house, even if it does not help there for various other matters, since the mourner's prayer is blocked[2] because the Divine Presence does not rest amidst sadness. This is especially true since the primary cause of sadness is the loss of the body, which is the external part that descends to dust so that the evil inclination within it may be destroyed.[3] And surely 90R 95R

[1] This refers to the Aramaic translation of the Kedushah prayer that appears in U'va L'Tzion. The author suggests that this translation has the spiritual power to counteract the cosmic structure of evil forces, symbolized by Nebuchadnezzar's dream-image in the Book of Daniel.

[2] There is a traditional concept that mourners have diminished spiritual access due to their state of grief and ritual impurity. The author acknowledges this limitation while still advocating for the recitation of the incense prayer in houses of mourning.

[3] This reflects the kabbalistic view that death and decomposition serve a spiritual purpose by eliminating the physical vessel that houses the evil inclination, allowing for the soul's purification.

[i] Refers to Nebuchadnezzar's dream in Daniel 2 of a statue with a head of gold, chest of silver, belly of bronze, legs of iron, and feet of mixed iron and clay, which was destroyed by a stone 'not cut by hands.'

[ii] Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd) is a section of the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism, purportedly recording the teachings of Moses.

אלו להחליש כחות דיני הקבר
המתרבות עליו בימים ההם כי
חסדי ה׳ לא תמו ואין להתעצם
ולהקשות באמור כי ח״ו זה
יהיה כגירא בעיניה דשטנא כמו
שאמרו דורשי רשומות בהזכרת
פסוק ועתה יגדל נא כח אדנ״י
בלילה כי יעצו לומר כי יד על
כס יה חלופו וכן בי״ג מדות
אמרו שאין להזכירם בתחלת
הלילה משום לא תחסום שור
בדישו[i] כמו שאמרו ג״כ על
תקיעת שופר בלילה שאין ענין
לזה כלל שכבר עשה שליחותו
ואחר האש קול דממה דקה לבסם
ולתבל העולם:[ii]

the soul of the departed certainly benefits from the
breath that rises when mentioning the power of these 100R
ingredients, weakening the forces of grave judgment
that increase upon him in those days, for the mercies
of the Lord have not ceased.

One should not stubbornly object to this, for
God forbid, this would be like "an arrow in Satan's 105R
eye,"[A] as the interpreters of scriptural allusions have
said regarding the verse "And now, may the power
of the Lord be magnified" at night, because they ad-
vised saying "For a hand is on the throne of Yah"
as its substitution. Similarly, regarding the Thirteen 110R
Attributes [of Mercy], they said they should not be
mentioned at the beginning of the night because of
[the principle] "You shall not muzzle an ox while it
treads," just as they also said regarding the blowing
of the shofar at night that it has no relevance at 115R
all, for it has already fulfilled its mission, and after
the fire comes "a still, small voice"[1] to sweeten and

[A] Or: "And one should not be obstinate or raise difficulties about this, for Heaven forbid, it would be like "shooting an arrow into Satan's eye,"" — The alternate translation unpacks the idiom more fully and makes explicit the metaphorical action of 'shooting' which is implied in the original. This might be clearer for readers unfamiliar with this Talmudic expression.

[1] This alludes to 1 Kings 19:12, where Elijah encounters God not in wind, earthquake, or fire, but in a 'still, small voice.' The author uses this to metaphorically describe how after the shofar's loud blast has completed its spiritual work, a gentler process of sweetening judgment takes place.

[i] This refers to a kabbalistic concern about reciting the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy at night. The phrase 'You shall not muzzle an ox while it treads' (Deuteronomy 25:4) is applied metaphorically, suggesting that reciting these attributes at night might inappropriately restrain certain spiritual processes.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas, 294a — The author directly quotes the Zohar to establish the power of the ketoret (incense) ritual to eliminate plague and bind judgment with mercy. This reference serves as a primary authoritative source for the author's main argument about the importance of reciting the Pitum HaKetoret even in a house of mourning. | Cf. Yom Kippur Temple service — The opening paragraphs allude to the detailed Temple ritual for Yom Kippur described in Tractate Yoma, particularly the High Priest's preparation and offering of the incense in the Holy of Holies. This reference establishes the sacred precedent for the incense ritual that the author is advocating for regular practice. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayakhel — The author references the Zohar section on Vayakhel to support his recommendation about when to recite the Pitum HaKetoret prayer. This establishes the mystical tradition for the proper timing of this ritual in the prayer service. | Cf. Book of Daniel, regarding Nebuchadnezzar — The allusion to Nebuchadnezzar and the stone 'not cut by hands' references Daniel 2:34 and Daniel 4:25-33. The author interprets these passages as symbolizing the defeat of evil forces through proper ritual, connecting biblical narrative to kabbalistic practice. | Cf. Maimonides on medicinal compounds — The reference to Maimonides' warning about medicinal compounds like theriac shows how the author integrates medical knowledge with mystical concepts, suggesting that spiritual remedies, like physical ones, must be applied properly to be effective rather than harmful. | Cf. Leviticus 16:12-13 — The text alludes to the biblical description of the High Priest's incense offering on Yom Kippur, using this as the foundation for understanding the cosmic significance of the incense ritual and its power to transform judgment into mercy. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:33-35 — The reference to "the cruel venom of serpents" and "hidden with Me, sealed in My treasuries" draws from Deuteronomy 32:33-35. The author interprets these verses kabbalistically to explain how negative forces are incorporated into divine service through the inclusion of the foul-smelling galbanum in the sacred incense.

season the world.

פרק ה׳

Chapter 5

עוד מצאתי כי הקטרת הוא לרצות מדת הדין ומטעם זה עוצר המגפה כי תתרוה צמאונה ולא תקטרג בסוד שעיר המשתלח לעזאזל.[i] ובשיר השירים על פסוק אלך לי אל הר המור אמר וכל מזיקים ומחבלים הוו ערקין מריח קטרת בוסמיא. וכיון שהוא לרצון מדה״ד ודאי שאין לחוש להתנגדות ח״ו. ולא לחנם תקנוהו מסדרי התפלות אחר קדיש תתקבל שמשם ואילך יש שני קדישין קדיש הראשון אומרים אותו לצנן הגהינם על כל מתי עולם בכלל וקדיש של עלינו לשבח נקרא קדיש יתום שאומר אותו הבן על אביו או אמו.[ii] הנה שבוונו לסדר קדיש לכל מתי עולם אחר אמירת סדר זה המבסם דיני גהינם בכחו הנאדרי ונוסף עליו כח הקדיש שלאחריו שמצנן אש גהינם שעתא

I have also found that the incense offering serves to appease the attribute of judgment,[1] and for this reason it stops plagues, as it quenches its thirst and prevents it from accusing,[A] similar to the scapegoat sent to Azazel.[2] And in the Song of Songs, regarding the verse "I will go to the mountain of myrrh," it states that all harmful spirits and destroyers flee from the scent of the aromatic incense.[3] Since it is designed to appease the attribute of judgment, there is certainly no need to worry about opposition, God forbid.[B] And it was not without reason that the arrangers of prayers established it after the Kaddish Titkabel, for from that point onward there are two Kaddish prayers: the first Kaddish is recited to cool Gehenna for all the dead of the world in general, and the Kaddish of Aleinu L'Shabeach is called the Orphan's Kaddish, which a son recites for his father or mother. Thus, they intended to arrange a Kaddish for all the dead of the world after the recitation of this order which sweetens the judgments of Gehenna with its majestic power.[C] Added to this is the power of the Kaddish that follows it, which cools the fire of

5R 10R 15R 20R

[A] Or: "because it satisfies its thirst and prevents it from prosecuting" — The alternate translation provides a more direct rendering of the Hebrew 'tiktareg' (to prosecute/accuse) and clarifies the causal relationship implied by 'ki' (because).

[B] Or: "certainly there is no concern about provoking resistance, God forbid" — The alternate translation captures more precisely the idea of 'hitnagdut' as resistance or opposition that might be provoked, rather than just general opposition.

[C] Or: "which perfumes/sweetens the judgments of Gehenna with its glorious power" — The term 'mevasem' comes from the root for spice/perfume, and while 'sweetens' captures the metaphorical meaning well, 'perfumes' preserves the connection to the incense (ketoret) that is the subject of the passage. 'Glorious' is another valid translation of 'ne'edari'.

[1] The Hebrew term 'לרצות מדת הדין' carries the connotation of appeasing or satisfying the divine attribute of judgment, as if it were a spiritual entity with desires that need to be fulfilled to prevent it from exercising its severity.

[2] This refers to the Yom Kippur ritual described in Leviticus 16, where one goat was sacrificed and another sent to Azazel in the wilderness. In kabbalistic interpretation, this ritual served to distract or 'bribe' negative spiritual forces.

[3] The author references a Zoharic interpretation of Song of Songs 4:6 that associates the 'mountain of myrrh' with the protective powers of Temple incense against negative spiritual forces.

[i] The author draws a fascinating parallel between the incense offering and the scapegoat ritual of Yom Kippur, suggesting both function to satisfy or distract negative spiritual forces and prevent them from bringing accusations against Israel.

[ii] This passage reflects the kabbalistic understanding of the Kaddish prayer's function to provide relief to souls in Gehenna (Jewish conception of purgatory). The author distinguishes between the first Kaddish after the Amidah that benefits all souls and the Mourner's Kaddish specifically recited for one's parents.

ופלגא כאשר נתבאר בזהר בכמה מקומות[i] ולמורי הגאון מפאנו זצ״ל יש לו דברים עתיקים על זה בפרפרת רבתי שתקן על סוד הקדיש[ii] כנודע לכל משים עינו עליה. ומטעם זה נראה לי כי טוב להרגיל החולה לאומרו בעת חליו וסגולתו לבטל מרעין בישין ומותא בישא. ועוד השתא החולה דינא רדיף בתריה וכבר אמרנו בשם הזהר דגברא כי האי אצטריך לאדכרא עובדא דקטרת ואני הנהגתי בני ביתי אחר קצת פסוקים האומרים במוצאי שבת תיכף אחר ההבדלה שאז מתחילים כחות הדין והחצונים להתפשט בעולם אחר ברכת מאורי האש כאשר כתבנו למעלה אחר הבדלת הקדש מן החול בד׳ מיני הבדלות נגד ד׳ מיני קליפות המתראים באגוז[iii] אנו קוראים אחר פסוקים הסכר סדר פטום הקטרת עם שיר של פגעים וגם שהיא בלילה אין לחוש על זה. וכן בלילי ראש השנה טוב לאומרו עם איזה פסוקים וסדרים אשר לנו השייכות לשתי לילות החם למתק שני הנהגות הדין המזדמנים לשלוט בשני ימים טובים של ראש השנה בסוד המלך הקדוש והמלך המשפט האחד בחינת הדין הקשה והאחד בחינת הדין הרפה בסוד שברים

Gehenna for an hour and a half, as explained in the Zohar in several places. And my teacher, the Gaon of Fano, of blessed memory,[1] has profound insights on this in his extensive commentary that he composed on the secret of the Kaddish, as is known to anyone who examines it. 25R

For this reason, it seems to me that it is good to accustom the sick person to recite it during his illness, as it has the special power to nullify evil diseases and malignant death. Furthermore, now that the sick person is pursued by judgment, we have already said in the name of the Zohar that such a person needs to recite the work of the incense offering. I have trained my household to recite, after some verses that are said at the conclusion of the Sabbath, immediately after Havdalah—when the forces of judgment and the external forces begin to spread throughout the world after the blessing over the fire, as we wrote above—after the separation of the holy from the profane with the four types of separations corresponding to the four types of shells that appear in a nut,[2] we read after these verses the order of the Preparation of the Incense together with the Song of Afflictions [Psalm 91], and even though it is nighttime, there is no need for concern about this. 30R 35R 40R 45R

Similarly, on the nights of Rosh Hashanah, it is good to recite it with certain verses and orders that we have that relate to those two nights, to sweeten the two modes of judgment that are poised to rule on the two festival days of Rosh Hashanah—the secret of "the Holy King" and "the King of Judgment"—one being the aspect of severe judgment and the other the aspect of lenient judgment,[3] in the secret of the Shevarim and Teruah [shofar sounds], and the se- 50R 55R

[1] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (c.1548-1620), an important Italian kabbalist who was influenced by both the teachings of Moses Cordovero and Isaac Luria. The author identifies him as his teacher, establishing his intellectual lineage.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the four kelipot (shells/husks), which are layers of spiritual impurity surrounding holiness, often compared to the layers of a nut surrounding the edible part.

[3] The author is referring to kabbalistic interpretations of the two days of Rosh Hashanah, each associated with different aspects of divine judgment (din) that correspond to different shofar sounds.

[i] The specified time period that Kaddish cools Gehenna (an hour and a half) reflects the precise timekeeping that characterizes kabbalistic approaches to prayer efficacy.

[ii] The author identifies Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano (c.1548-1620) as his teacher, confirming his intellectual lineage within Italian Kabbalah. The reference to 'ancient matters' (דברים עתיקים) likely refers to kabbalistic teachings tracing back to earlier sources.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of four layers of negative spiritual forces (kelipot) that are compared to the layers of a nut, with each requiring a different type of separation/havdalah to overcome. This metaphor appears in early kabbalistic works like the Bahir.

ותרועה וסוד בית דין עליון
ובית דין תחתון וכן בליל שלפני
מילת התינוק מה טוב לאמרו
60 לפני כסא אליהו עם שירי דוד
כי המכין לכסא הלז בקדושה
ובטהרה ומזמינו בפיו יזכה
להארת פניו ואי אי אליהו לא יחזי
מזליה שברקיע יחזי[i] כאשר
65 הודענו למעלה מהו המזל
הזה. לא כאלו שמתלוצצים
הלילה ההוא אנשים עם נשים
שהוא כאש בנעורת[ii] וגברים עם
טף. פוקו חזו מה היו עושים
70 דורות הראשונים דלא הוו פסקי
פומייהו מגרסא כל אותה הלילה
בסודות המילה כנראה בספר
הזהר סוף פרשת לך לך. ואם
כן קריאת פטום הקטרת עם
75 שירי דוד לפניו ולאחריו יועיל
ודאי לתנוק המוכן להראות
קרבן שי ומנחה לפני המלך ה׳
צבאות ביום שלאחריו בתוספת
נפש רוח ונשמה בכח אור כי
80 יהל עליו[iii] כל היום ההוא
וכל העם ההולכים לברית
מילה הם כמקבלים פני שכינה
הבאה להופיעה מאורה על כל
המטפלים במצוה ההיא[iv] ויש
85 להם תוספת נשמה גם כן לכן

cret of the upper court and the lower court. And likewise, on the night before a child's circumcision, how good it is to recite it before Elijah's chair along with David's songs, for one who prepares this chair in 60R
holiness and purity and summons it with his mouth will merit the illumination of his countenance, and if he himself does not see it, his celestial guardian angel will see it,[A] as we have explained above what this celestial influence is. 65R

Not like those who mock on that night—men with women, which is like fire in flax,[1] and men with children. Go and see what the earlier generations used to do, whose mouths did not cease from study the entire night, [delving into] the secrets of circumcision, 70R
as can be seen in the Book of the Zohar at the end of Parashat Lech Lecha. And if so, the recitation of the Preparation of the Incense with David's songs before and after it will certainly benefit the child who is prepared to be presented as an offering and gift be- 75R
fore the King, the LORD of Hosts, on the following day, with an additional soul, spirit, and higher soul through the power of light that will shine upon him throughout that day. And all the people who go to a circumcision covenant are like those who receive the 80R
Divine Presence that comes to shine its light upon all who are involved in that commandment, and they too have an additional soul.[2] Therefore, they said that their festival day is like a festival day when there is an additional soul. And therefore, all the people 85R

[A] Or: "and if he himself does not see it, his mazal in the firmament will see it" — Keeping the kabbalistic term 'mazal' untranslated better preserves the technical meaning of this concept, which refers to a person's spiritual root or celestial counterpart, not precisely a 'guardian angel' in the conventional sense.

[1] The author criticizes social mixing between men and women during the night before a circumcision as spiritually inappropriate. This metaphor of 'fire in flax' (אש בנעורת) is a traditional rabbinic expression for a dangerous situation that will inevitably lead to problems.

[2] The concept of 'neshamah yeteirah' (additional soul) is traditionally associated with Sabbath and festivals. The author extends this concept to participants in a circumcision ceremony, elevating this ritual to a status comparable to major Jewish holidays.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'mazal' as a celestial counterpart or higher spiritual root of each person that may perceive spiritual realities even when the person themselves cannot.

[ii] The comparison of mixing between men and women to 'fire in flax' is a common rabbinic expression warning against potentially dangerous situations that could lead to improper behavior. Here the author criticizes inappropriate socializing during the night before a circumcision.

[iii] The author describes the spiritual benefit to the child being circumcised as receiving additional levels of soul—nefesh, ruach, and neshamah—through the light that shines upon him. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that spiritual actions open channels for higher levels of soul to enter a person.

[iv] This reflects the mystical concept that the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) literally manifests at a circumcision ceremony, bestowing spiritual light on all participants.

אמרו שיום טוב שלהם הוא כמו שבים טוב יש נשמה יתירה.[i] ולכן חייבים כל העם לעמוד בעמידה בשעת המילה. ואסמכוהו על פסוק ויעמוד העם בברית. ומדרגות הנשמות הבאות לאדם כפי מעשיו מתבאר בזהר פרשת משפטים דף צ״ד באר היטב יעויין שם. וכן התלבשות הנשמה ברוח שבגן עדן עליון וברוח אחר שבגן עדן תחתון ואיך שוכנת בכל שני רוחות אלו בעולם הזה ומוצא הנשמה והרוח שהוא מבינה ויסוד הכל מתבאר שם דף צ״ו וצ״ז:[ii]

are obligated to stand during the circumcision, and they based this on the verse "And the people stood at the covenant."

The levels of souls that come to a person according to his deeds are explained well in the Zohar, Parashat Mishpatim, page 94, as can be examined there. And likewise, the enclothing of the soul in the spirit that is in the upper Garden of Eden and in another spirit that is in the lower Garden of Eden,[1] and how it dwells in both of these spirits in this world, and the origin of the soul and spirit, which is from Binah,[2] and the foundation of everything, is explained there on pages 96 and 97.

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

סדר אמירת פטום הקטרת הנזכר בכל מקום ובכל זמן ראוי לומר אותו כלל ואח״כ פרט בתחלה אומר הפסוקים כאשר

The order for reciting the Preparation of the Incense mentioned in every place and time is that one should first recite it in general and then in detail. First, one should recite the biblical verses as they are written

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic understanding of how the soul manifests differently in various spiritual realms. The upper and lower Gardens of Eden (Gan Eden) are distinct spiritual domains where different components of the soul reside.

[2] In kabbalistic cosmology, Binah (Understanding) is the third of the ten sefirot (divine emanations) and is understood as the source from which souls originate. This places the soul's origin at a very high level in the divine structure.

[i] The author extends the concept of neshamah yeteirah (additional soul) beyond Sabbath and festivals to include participation in a circumcision ceremony, elevating this ritual to a status comparable to major Jewish holidays.

[ii] Cf. Zohar on Song of Songs, 'I will go to the mountain of myrrh' — The reference to Song of Songs supports the author's claim about the protective power of incense against harmful spiritual forces. The Zohar interprets 'mountain of myrrh' as an allusion to the Temple incense. | Cf. Concept of the scapegoat to Azazel — The author compares the incense's power to appease judgment to the scapegoat ritual, suggesting both serve as forms of spiritual 'distraction' that prevent divine accusation against Israel. | Cf. The Zohar's teaching on Kaddish cooling Gehenna — The author is building on established Zoharic teachings about the Kaddish prayer's power to provide relief to souls in Gehenna to further argue for the efficacy of the Ketoret (incense offering) recitation. | Cf. Elijah's chair at circumcision — The author extends the spiritual power of the Ketoret recitation to the circumcision ritual, suggesting that proper preparation of Elijah's chair with appropriate prayers creates a spiritually potent environment that can be perceived by celestial forces even if not by humans. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Lech Lecha on circumcision — The author cites this section of the Zohar to contrast contemporary practices at circumcision ceremonies with the ideal practice of studying the mystical secrets of circumcision throughout the night before the ceremony. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Mishpatim on soul levels — The author references this Zohar passage to support his discussion of how souls are granted to individuals based on their spiritual level and deeds, particularly in the context of additional souls received during sacred occasions. | Cf. Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano on Kaddish — The author identifies Rabbi Menahem Azariah of Fano as his teacher and refers to his writings on the mystical dimensions of the Kaddish prayer, suggesting this is an important source for understanding the power of Kaddish to alleviate suffering in Gehenna.

הם כתובים בתורה וצריך לומר אותם בנגונם וכטעמם ואח״כ מפרט ענין פטימתו במבואר בגמ׳ בריתות פרק קמא. וצריך שיאמר כל ענייניו כלם ולא יחסר אפי׳ אחד מהם והזהיר בו אינו בא לידי עניות כדאמרי׳ חדשים לקטרת וכו׳[i] ונציג לפנינו נסחו כאשר בא מרבני וגאוני מנטובה זצ״ל קדושים אשר בארץ עם תוספת מעט. ואל נא יאשימוני חכמים המורגלים לדבר צחות ובלשון קצרה[ii] כי למה לי לאסוף מן המפוזר בספר הזהר בענין זה כי באמת היה די למורה מקום כאשר עשיתי בהרבה דרושים כאשר עיני הקורא תחזינה. אך האלהים הוא יודע כי כוונתי להציע הדברים כהוייתן לעין כל קורא בזה אולי אזכה ואסק שע״פ דברי הזהר המתפרטים לפני איזה יחידים או רבים אולי ירגילו עצמם בקריאתו פטום הקטרת הזה פעמים בכל יום ושמעתי כי במקומות הרבה מקהילות

in the Torah, and one must recite them with their proper melody and cantillation.[A] Afterward, one elaborates on the matter of its preparation as explained in the Talmud, Tractate Keritot, first chapter. One must recite all its details completely, without omitting even one of them. One who is careful with this will not come to poverty,[B] as we say, "Those appointed to prepare new incense..."[1] etc. 5R 10R

I will present before you its text as it came from the rabbis and sages of Mantua, of blessed memory,[2] holy ones who were in the land, with some small additions. Let not the wise who are accustomed to speaking elegantly and concisely blame me[3] for why I gather from scattered places in the Zohar on this matter, for indeed it would have been sufficient to merely indicate the source as I have done in many discourses, as the reader's eyes will see. But God knows that my intention is to present the matters as they are before the eyes of every reader of this, so that perhaps I will merit and succeed that, based on the words of the Zohar that are detailed before some individuals or many, perhaps they will accustom themselves to reading this Preparation of the Incense twice every day. 15R 20R 25R

I have heard that in many places among the Ashkenazic communities—may God protect them— 30R

[A] Or: "and one needs to recite them with their proper musical notation and accents" — The alternate translation uses more technical terms to describe the musical aspects of Torah reading, which might be clearer to readers familiar with cantillation systems but potentially less accessible to general readers.

[B] Or: "One who is meticulous about this will never be impoverished" — This alternate translation emphasizes the absolute nature of the protection against poverty that proper recitation of the incense prayer is believed to provide, which may more accurately reflect the strength of the belief in this tradition.

[1] This is a reference to the Talmudic teaching that the Temple incense service was performed by priests who had never before prepared it, with the service rotating among different priests. The full quote continues to explain that this was because the incense service was believed to bring wealth to those who performed it.

[2] Mantua was an important center of Jewish learning in Renaissance Italy, with a respected rabbinical academy. The author is indicating that his version of the Pitum HaKetoret prayer comes from authoritative sources from this prestigious community.

[3] This is a rhetorical device common in rabbinic literature where the author preemptively addresses potential criticism of his writing style. In this case, the author acknowledges that his comprehensive compilation might seem excessive to some scholarly readers who prefer concision.

[i] This is a reference to a Talmudic teaching (Yoma 26a) about how the preparation of the Temple incense was rotated among different priestly families, specifically that priests who had never before prepared the incense were given preference, as this service was believed to bring wealth to those who performed it.

[ii] The author is making a humble apology to scholarly readers who might prefer a more concise presentation. This reflects the common rabbinic literary convention of humility, while also indicating that the author is aware his detailed compilation might seem excessive to some readers.

אשכנז ישמרם ה׳ שהיה להם מנהג שלא לאומרו רק בשבת מן הטעם שכתב מהר״י אבוה״ב בארחות חיים[i] הגם שנדחו דבריו מאחרונים ובפרט ממהר״י קאר״ו ז״ל כנראה באו״ח סי׳ קל״ג מ״מ על פי דברי חכמים קצת מאותם הקהילות הנהיגו עצמם לאומרו שחרית וערבית. והרב המגיה בסי׳ קל״ב[ii] מאד זירז על זה הגם כי מדרכו לקיים המנהגים. וכן ראוי לעשות אך לא תהיה קריאתו עראי כמנהגנו רק בקבע ובכוונה כי בזה יוסר משפטינו ויפלו אויבינו[iii] ואז נצליח את דרכינו ואז נשכיל ורב טוב לבית ישראל: [iv]

they had the custom not to recite it except on the Sabbath,[1] for the reason that Rabbi Joseph Abudarham wrote in Orchot Chaim, even though his words were rejected by later authorities, particularly by Rabbi Joseph Karo of blessed memory, as appears in Orach Chaim, section 133. Nevertheless, based on the words of some sages from those communities, they instituted the practice of reciting it morning and evening. The Rav who annotated in section 132 strongly encouraged this, even though it is his way to uphold customs. And so it is fitting to do, but its recitation should not be casual as is our custom, but rather with regularity and intention,[A] for through this our judgment will be removed and our enemies will fall,[2] and then we will make our way successful, and then we will gain insight, and much good will come to the house of Israel.

זה סדר המסודר מפי גאוני ורבני מנטובה[v] קדושים אשר

This is the order arranged by the sages and rabbis of Mantua,[3] holy ones who are in the land, may God

[A] Or: "with fixed consistency and proper kavvanah (mystical intention)" — The alternate translation preserves the technical term 'kavvanah' which has specific meaning in Jewish mysticism, referring to the focused spiritual intention that should accompany ritual acts.

[1] The author is addressing a liturgical controversy regarding how frequently the Pitum HaKetoret should be recited. While some Ashkenazic communities limited its recitation to Sabbaths only, the author advocates for twice-daily recitation, citing authorities like Rabbi Joseph Karo to support this practice.

[2] The author attributes protective powers to the proper recitation of the incense prayer, suggesting it can avert divine judgment and defeat enemies. This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the Temple incense had special power to ward off plagues and harmful spiritual forces.

[3] The author is attributing this prayer sequence to the rabbinic authorities of Mantua rather than claiming it as his own composition, showing respect for their liturgical tradition.

[i] The author is referring to Rabbi Joseph Abudarham (not to be confused with David Abudarham) and his work. 'Orchot Chaim' was a halakhic compendium, but there is some confusion in the attribution since the more famous work by this name was by Rabbi Aaron of Lunel.

[ii] This likely refers to Rabbi Moses Isserles (the Rema), who wrote glosses on the Shulchan Aruch, adding Ashkenazic customs to Rabbi Joseph Karo's predominantly Sephardic rulings.

[iii] The author attributes protective powers to the proper recitation of the incense prayer, suggesting it can avert divine judgment and defeat enemies. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the incense offering had special power to neutralize negative forces.

[iv] Cf. Tractate Keritot — The author refers to the Talmudic source that details the preparation of the Temple incense, establishing that this prayer text is based on an authoritative religious source. | Cf. Zohar — The author mentions gathering material from the Zohar about the incense offering, indicating that this prayer has mystical significance beyond its literal meaning, with the Zohar providing the kabbalistic interpretations. | Cf. Orach Chaim — The author cites Rabbi Joseph Karo's legal code to establish that the recitation of the incense passage should be a daily practice, not limited to Sabbaths as some communities practiced. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, earlier sections — The author's reference to "as I have done in many discourses" indicates that this section follows the same organizational pattern as previous sections of Ma'avar Yabok, providing both practical instructions and deeper mystical interpretations.

[v] Mantua was an important center of Jewish learning in northern Italy during the 16th-17th centuries, known for its rabbinic scholarship and kabbalistic traditions. The author shows deference to the rabbinic authorities of this community.

50 [ii] [i]באריך יח״ב. preserve them. 50R

מזמור יושב בסתר עליון
סימן צ״א[iii] תמצא לעיל סדר
א׳:[iv] יענך ה׳ ביום צרה סדר
ב׳:[v] מזמור לדוד להזכיר
55 סימן ל״ח סדר ד׳[vi] ואחר כך
יאמר:[vii]

Psalm “He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High”[1] (number 91) can be found above in Order 1; “May the LORD answer you in the day of trouble”[2] in Order 2; “A Psalm of David, to bring to remembrance”[3] (number 38) in Order 4; and after that he shall recite:[4] 55R

וַיְמַהֵר אַבְרָהָם הָאֹהֱלָה אֶל שָׂרָה
וַיֹּאמֶר מַהֲרִי שְׁלֹשׁ סְאִים קֶמַח
סלֶת[viii] לוּשִׁי וַעֲשִׂי עֻגוֹת: (ג׳
60 פעמים[ix]) וַיֹּאמֶר אֲלֵהֶם יִשְׂרָאֵל
אֲבִיהֶם אִם כֵּן אֵפוֹא זֹאת עֲשׂוּ קְחוּ
מִזִּמְרַת הָאָרֶץ בִּכְלֵיכֶם וְהוֹרִידוּ
לָאִישׁ מִנְחָה מְעַט צֳרִי וּמְעַט דְּבַשׁ

“And Abraham hastened to the tent to Sarah, and said: ‘Make haste, prepare three measures of fine meal, knead it, and make cakes.’” (three times[5]) “And Israel their father said to them: ‘If it must be so, then do this: take of the choice fruits of the land in your vessels, and carry down to the man a present, a little balm, and a little honey, gum, ladanum, pis- 60R

[1]This is the opening line of Psalm 91, which is identified by number (91) in the original text.
[2]This is the opening line of Psalm 20, which is not identified by number in the original text.
[3]This is the opening line of Psalm 38, which is identified by number (38) in the original text.
[4]This instruction indicates that what follows in the text (not included in this segment) should be recited after the previously mentioned psalms.
[5]This parenthetical instruction indicates that the preceding verse should be recited three times as part of the prayer ritual, a common practice in Jewish liturgy to emphasize important passages.

[i]An acronym likely standing for ‘ישמרם חונן בריותיו’ (May He who is gracious to His creatures preserve them) or a similar blessing formula.
[ii]Cf. Ma’avar Yabok, Section 4 (Eter Anan HaKetoret) — This line introduces a prayer sequence for the Ketoret (incense) ritual that was arranged by the rabbinical authorities of Mantua, Italy. The author of Ma’avar Yabok is showing deference to these authorities by explicitly attributing this prayer order to them rather than claiming it as his own composition.
[iii]This refers to Psalm 91, known in rabbinic tradition as “Song of Afflictions” (Shir Shel Pegaim), which was considered to have special protective properties against harmful spiritual forces.
[iv]Ma’avar Yabok contains eight distinct liturgical sequences (sedarim) for the sick and dying. This is referring to the first such sequence.
[v]This refers to the second liturgical sequence in Ma’avar Yabok, which includes Psalm 20, with its themes of divine support in times of trouble.
[vi]This refers to the fourth liturgical sequence in Ma’avar Yabok, which includes Psalm 38, a penitential psalm appropriate for the sick.
[vii]Cf. Psalm 91 — This psalm appears in multiple liturgical sequences in Ma’avar Yabok, particularly for protection of the sick and dying. It’s considered especially effective against harmful spiritual entities that might interfere with the soul’s peaceful transition. | Cf. Psalm 20 — This psalm, with its themes of divine support in times of trouble and confidence in divine salvation, is particularly appropriate for those experiencing serious illness. | Cf. Psalm 38 — This psalm appears in the fourth liturgical sequence, likely due to its themes of physical suffering, confession of sin, and plea for divine mercy, making it particularly relevant for the sick who might be examining their lives and seeking spiritual healing alongside physical recovery. | Cf. Seder (liturgical sequence) — This passage is referencing the organizational structure of Ma’avar Yabok’s prayer sequences, directing the reader to specific psalms found in different ‘Orders’ (Sedarim). This shows how the book functioned as a practical manual with clear cross-references to help users navigate between sections.
[viii]This phrase from Genesis 18:6 describes Abraham’s hospitality to the three divine visitors. The fine flour (solet) was considered the best quality, suitable for important guests and offerings.
[ix]The instruction to recite this verse three times is part of the ritual formula of the prayer, possibly reflecting the three visitors in the original biblical story or creating a threefold invocation of Abraham’s spiritual merit.

נְכֹאת וָלֹט בָּטְנִים וּשְׁקֵדִים:[i][ii] tachio nuts, and almonds.'[1]"

וצריך לכוין בר״ת[iii] של "צרי "דבש "נכאת "לוט "בטנים "ושקדים:[iv] ואח״כ אומר[v] One should focus on the initial letters[2] of "tzori" (balm), "devash" (honey), "nechot" (gum), "lot" (ladanum), "botnim" (pistachios), and "ushkedim" (almonds). And afterwards one recites:[3] 65R

רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם בִּזְמַן שֶׁבֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ קַיָּם הָיוּ אֲבוֹתֵינוּ וְכֹהֲנֵינוּ מַקְרִיבִים לְפָנֶיךָ אֶת קְטֹרֶת Master of the Universe,[4] when the Temple stood, our ancestors and our priests would offer before You the incense of spices, and atonement was made for them. 70R

[1] These verses serve as part of the prayer for the incense offering (Ketoret). The practice of reciting biblical verses about offerings and gifts helps establish a framework for prayer as a substitute for the Temple offerings. This substitution became particularly important after the destruction of the Temple when physical offerings could no longer be brought.

[2] The Hebrew instruction indicates a kabbalistic meditation practice where one concentrates on the first letters of these six items. While not explicitly stated in this segment, these letters likely form a meaningful acronym or divine name that would be contemplated during the incense offering prayer ritual.

[3] This phrase introduces the prayer that follows, though the actual prayer text is not included in this segment. The colon indicates that the prayer text would begin immediately after this instruction.

[4] This opening address (Ribbono shel Olam) is a common form of direct appeal to God in Jewish prayer, particularly in personal supplications. It emphasizes the universal sovereignty of God beyond the confines of Jewish peoplehood.

[i] The items listed in Genesis 43:11 have mystical significance in this context. Kabbalistic sources note that the first letters of "צָרִי וּמְעַט דְּבַשׁ נְכֹאת וָלֹט בָּטְנִים וּשְׁקֵדִים" form an acronym that is considered to have protective powers.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 18:6 — This verse from Genesis about Abraham's hospitality is cited here as part of a ritual prayer text in the incense offering section. The hasty preparation of food for divine guests is symbolically connected to the preparation of offerings to God, particularly the Temple incense. This verse emphasizes Abraham's eagerness to serve, which would resonate with the prayer's theme of offering service to God. | Cf. Genesis 43:11 — This verse about Jacob sending choice products of the land as gifts parallels the offering of incense ingredients. Just as Jacob's sons carried these items to appease a powerful figure (unknowingly their brother Joseph), the worshipper symbolically presents choice offerings to God. The specific items mentioned (balm, honey, etc.) may also evoke the aromatic components of the incense offering, creating a sensory parallel to the ketoret ritual.

[iii] Abbreviation for "rashei teivot" meaning "initial letters" or "acronym," referring to the practice of deriving mystical significance from the first letters of words.

[iv] This instruction refers to a kabbalistic practice of meditation on the initial letters of these six items mentioned in Genesis 43:11, where Jacob instructs his sons to take these products as gifts to the ruler of Egypt (Joseph). The initial letters form an acrostic that was considered to have mystical protective properties. Such letter-based meditations were common in kabbalistic prayer practices, especially in rituals intended to provide spiritual protection.

[v] Cf. Genesis 43:11 — The use of these specific items in this ritual prayer context demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok draws connections between biblical narratives and prayer practices. The items Jacob sent to preserve life in Egypt are here repurposed in a ritual context related to the incense offering, which itself was associated with protection from death and plague. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Eter Anan HaKetoret — The instruction to meditate on these initial letters fits within the broader theme of this section: creating spiritual connections through prayer that parallel the effects of the Temple incense offering. Letter-based meditations were common in kabbalistic practice as a means of connecting the physical act of prayer with spiritual realities.

הַסַּמִּים[i] וּמִתְכַּפֵּר עָלֵינוּ וְעַכְשָׁיו
בַּעֲוֹנוֹתֵינוּ חָרַב בֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ
וּבָמְלָה הָעֲבוֹדָה וְאֵין לָנוּ לֹא
מִזְבֵּחַ וְלֹא קָרְבָּן וְלֹא קְטֹרֶת
הַסַּמִּים וְלֹא כֹהֵן גָּדוֹל שֶׁיְּכַפֵּר
בַּעֲדֵנוּ אֶלָּא שִׂיחַ שִׂפְתוֹתֵינוּ
כְּמוֹ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר וּנְשַׁלְּמָה פָרִים
שִׂפְתֵינוּ[ii] לָכֵן אָנוּ מַזְכִּירִים
לְפָנֶיךָ אֶת קְרֻבַּן קְטֹרֶת הַסַּמִּים
אֲשֶׁר צִוִּיתָ אֶת אֲבוֹתֵינוּ בַּמִּדְבָּר
כְּמוֹ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר וַיֹּאמֶר יְיָ אֶל מֹשֶׁה
קַח לְךָ סַמִּים נָטָף וּשְׁחֵלֶת
וְחֶלְבְּנָה[iii] סַמִּים וּלְבֹנָה זַכָּה בַּד
בְּבַד יִהְיֶה:[iv] וְעָשִׂיתָ אֹתָהּ קְטֹרֶת
רֹקַח מַעֲשֵׂה רוֹקֵחַ מְמֻלָּח טָהוֹר
קֹדֶשׁ: וְשָׁחַקְתָּ מִמֶּנָּה הָדֵק וְנָתַתָּה
מִמֶּנָּה לִפְנֵי הָעֵדֻת בְּאֹהֶל מוֹעֵד
אֲשֶׁר אִוָּעֵד לְךָ שָׁמָּה קֹדֶשׁ קָדָשִׁים
תִּהְיֶה לָכֶם: וְהַקְּטֹרֶת אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשֶׂה
בְּמַתְכֻּנְתָּהּ לֹא תַעֲשׂוּ לָכֶם קֹדֶשׁ
תִּהְיֶה לְךָ לַיְיָ: וְהִקְטִיר עָלָיו
אַהֲרֹן קְטֹרֶת סַמִּים בַּבֹּקֶר בַּבֹּקֶר
בְּהֵיטִיבוֹ אֶת הַנֵּרֹת יַקְטִירֶנָּה:
וּבְהַעֲלֹת אַהֲרֹן אֶת הַנֵּרֹת בֵּין

But now, because of our sins,[1] the Temple is destroyed, the service has ceased, and we have neither altar, nor offering, nor incense of spices, nor High Priest to make atonement for us—only the meditation of our lips,[2] as it is said: "And let us offer the words of our lips instead of calves." Therefore, we recall before You the offering of the incense of spices which You commanded our ancestors in the wilderness, as it is said: "And the Lord said to Moses: Take for yourself spices—stacte, onycha, and galbanum[3]—spices and pure frankincense; they shall be of equal weight. And you shall make it into incense, a compound according to the art of the perfumer, well-blended, pure, and holy. And you shall beat some of it very fine, and put some of it before the Testimony in the Tent of Meeting where I will meet with you; it shall be most holy to you. And the incense which you shall make according to its composition, you shall not make for yourselves; it shall be holy to you for the Lord. And Aaron shall burn on it incense of spices; each morning when he tends the lamps he shall burn it. And when Aaron lights the lamps at twilight, he shall burn it, a perpetual incense before the Lord throughout your generations."[4]

[1]This phrase reflects the traditional Jewish theological understanding that the destruction of the Temple and the consequent exile were divine punishments for Israel's sins, particularly baseless hatred among Jews. This concept is fundamental to Jewish penitential prayers.

[2]The Hebrew term 'siach siftoteinu' (meditation/utterance of our lips) represents the transformation of physical ritual into verbal prayer after the destruction of the Temple. This concept is central to rabbinic Judaism's adaptation to the post-Temple reality.

[3]These are the first three of the eleven ingredients of the Temple incense. The exact botanical identities of these ancient substances remain somewhat uncertain, though various traditions exist regarding their identification. The inclusion of galbanum, with its foul odor, alongside pleasant aromatics is often interpreted symbolically as teaching the importance of including all types of people in the community.

[4]The designation of the incense as 'perpetual' (tamid) and 'throughout your generations' emphasizes its eternal nature, which is why its recitation remains spiritually significant even after the physical practice has ceased. This concept supports the book's emphasis on prayer as a genuine substitute for Temple offerings.

[i]In Jewish mystical tradition, particularly emphasized in Ma'avar Yabok, the incense offering (ketoret) was considered the most spiritually powerful of all Temple rituals. It was believed to have protective properties against plague and negative spiritual forces, and to create unifications in the higher spiritual realms.

[ii]This quote from Hosea 14:3 is a key biblical source for the rabbinic concept that prayer serves as a substitute for Temple sacrifices. The verse literally means "and let us offer the words of our lips instead of calves," drawing a direct parallel between verbal expression and animal sacrifice.

[iii]Galbanum (chelbena) had a foul odor, yet was a required component of the Temple incense. The Talmud (Keritot 6b) derives from this that communal prayer should include even sinners among Israel. In Kabbalistic thought, as discussed elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok, the inclusion of this negative element symbolizes the integration and elevation of impurity within the sacred.

[iv]This phrase literally means "measure for measure it shall be" or "equal portions," but carries deeper mystical significance in Kabbalistic texts. It suggests the perfect balance of divine attributes that the incense was intended to create or restore.

95 הָעֲרֻבִים יַקְטִירֶנָּה קְטֹרֶת תָּמִיד
לִפְנֵי יְיָ לְדֹרֹתֵיכֶם: [i]

ושם כתוב לומר כל פסוק ג׳ פעמים[ii] אך לעניות דעתי[iii] נראה כי מי שאינו רוצה לאומרם רק פעם אחת אם יקראם בטעמיהם ונגוניהם[iv] יקובל ג״כ ברצון: ואח״כ יאמר פטום הקטורת[v] ככתוב שם ובסדורים שלנו עד מפני הכבוד[vi] ואח״כ יוסיף עליו: [vii]

And there it is written to recite each verse three times, but in my humble opinion, it seems that one who does not wish to recite them more than once, if he reads them with their proper cantillation and melodies, it will also be accepted favorably.[1] And afterward, he should recite the Pitum HaKetoret (Preparation of the Incense) as written there and in our prayer books[2] until "for the sake of honor," and afterward he should add to it:[3]

100R

תַּנְיָא רַבִּי נָתָן אוֹמֵר כְּשֶׁהוּא שׁוֹחֵק

It was taught: Rabbi Nathan says: When grinding

105R

[1]The Hebrew phrase "יקובל ג״כ ברצון" implies divine acceptance of the prayer. There is a subtle theological point being made here about the quality of the recitation being more important than mere repetition.

[2]The Hebrew "סדורים שלנו" (our prayer books) suggests that the author is referring to the specific prayer books used in his community or tradition, which may have contained a particular version of the Pitum HaKetoret text.

[3]The text ends with a colon, indicating that what follows in the original would be additional text to be recited after the standard Pitum HaKetoret prayer. This instruction is part of the author's guidance for proper prayer practice.

[i]Cf. Hosea 14:3 — This verse is quoted to establish the principle that in the absence of Temple sacrifices, prayer (the words of our lips) serves as a substitute for physical offerings. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this supports the theological framework that proper recitation of sacred texts can create the same spiritual effects as Temple rituals. | Cf. Exodus 30:34-38 — This biblical passage provides the divine instructions for the preparation of the Temple incense. The extensive quotation of these verses serves both to preserve their memory and to invoke their ritual power through recitation, in keeping with the book's principle that the words themselves contain spiritual efficacy. | Cf. Berakhot 26b — The prayer implicitly draws on the rabbinic concept that prayers were established as a direct replacement for Temple sacrifices. This concept is widely discussed in the Talmud and informs this entire section of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on prayer as substitute for Temple offerings.

[ii]The abbreviation "פעמים ג׳" means "three times" and refers to the practice of repeating each biblical verse three times when reciting the Ketoret (incense) prayer.

[iii]This phrase means "according to my humble opinion" and is a common rabbinic expression of modesty when offering an interpretation or ruling.

[iv]This refers to reading the biblical verses with their proper cantillation marks (te'amim) and traditional melodic patterns, suggesting that the proper musical rendition adds spiritual significance to the recitation.

[v]Pitum HaKetoret (Preparation of the Incense) is a prayer text recounting the preparation of the sacred incense used in the ancient Temple in Jerusalem. It is considered to have special protective powers and is recited daily in traditional Jewish liturgy.

[vi]"For the sake of honor" likely refers to a specific ending point in the prayer text that was commonly known to readers of this work. The phrase might come from a section in the Pitum HaKetoret text discussing why certain incense ingredients were included.

[vii]Cf. Earlier in Ma'avar Yabok, particularly in the sections discussing the protective power of the Ketoret — This reference connects to the author's earlier teachings about the Ketoret's importance, showing consistency in his view that this prayer has special significance but allowing some flexibility in its recitation methods. | Cf. Traditional Jewish liturgical practice regarding the Pitum HaKetoret — The author is acknowledging traditional practice while offering a more lenient approach, suggesting that proper intention and melody can compensate for lack of repetition, which reflects his practical approach to prayer throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

אוֹמֵר הָדֵק הֵיטֵב הֵיטֵב הָדֵק מִפְּנֵי
שֶׁהַקּוֹל יָפֶה לַבְּשָׂמִים.[i] פִּטְמָהּ
לַחֲצָאִין כְּשֵׁרָה לִשְׁלִישׁ וְלִרְבִיעַ
לֹא שָׁמַעְנוּ: אָמַר רַבִּי יְהוּדָה
זֶה הַכְּלָל אִם כְּמִדָּתָהּ כְּשֵׁרָה
לַחֲצָאִין וְאִם חִסֵּר אַחַת מִכָּל
סַמָּנֶיהָ חַיָּב מִיתָה:[ii] תָּנְיָא בַּר
קַפָּרָא אוֹמֵר אַחַת לְשִׁשִּׁים אוֹ
לְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה הָיְתָה בָּאָה שֶׁל
שִׁירַיִם לַחֲצָאִין:[iii] וְעוֹד תָּנֵי בַּר
קַפָּרָא אִלּוּ הָיָה נוֹתֵן בָּהּ קוֹרְטוֹב
שֶׁל דְּבַשׁ אֵין אָדָם יָכוֹל לַעֲמֹד
מִפְּנֵי רֵיחָהּ[iv] וְלָמָּה אֵין מְעָרְבִין
בָּהּ דְּבַשׁ מִפְּנֵי שֶׁהַתּוֹרָה אָמְרָה כִּי
כָל־שְׂאֹר וְכָל־דְּבַשׁ לֹא־תַקְטִירוּ
מִמֶּנּוּ אִשֶּׁה לַיהוָה:[v]

[the incense], one says[1] "Grind it well, well grind it," because the voice is beneficial for the spices. If one prepared half the required amount, it is valid; but regarding one-third or one-quarter, we have not heard [a ruling]. Rabbi Judah said: This is the general principle—if prepared according to its proper measure, half the amount is valid,[2] but if one omitted any of its ingredients, one is liable to death. Bar Kappara taught: Once in sixty or seventy years, the accumulated leftovers would amount to half[3] [the annual quantity]. Bar Kappara further taught: If one were to add even a tiny amount of honey to it, no person could withstand its fragrance.[4] And why is honey not mixed with it? Because the Torah stated: "For you shall not burn any leaven or any honey as an offering by fire to the LORD."

רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם בִּזְמַן שֶׁבֵּית
הַמִּקְדָּשׁ קַיָּם הָיָה כֹּהֵן גָּדוֹל
מַקְטִיר לְפָנֶיךָ קְרְבַּן קְטֹרֶת
הַסַּמִּים וּמְכַפֵּר עַל עַמְּךָ

Master of the Universe, in the time when the Temple stood, the High Priest would offer before You the sacrifice of the aromatic incense and atone for Your people Israel. And now, because of our sins, the Tem-

[1] The Temple practice described here involved vocalizing specific words during the grinding process, based on the belief that the sound vibrations positively affected the aromatic qualities of the spices.
[2] The Talmudic discussion distinguishes between preparing a half-measure (which is permitted) and omitting ingredients (which is forbidden). This reflects a principle that quantity can be reduced while maintaining the proper proportional formula, but the formula itself is inviolable.
[3] This refers to the practice of carefully collecting and storing small amounts of leftover incense from the daily preparation process. These leftovers would accumulate over decades until they amounted to half the annual quantity (about 365 manehs).
[4] The hypothetical addition of honey is described as creating an overwhelmingly powerful fragrance, yet despite this potential enhancement, honey was forbidden based on the biblical prohibition. This emphasizes strict adherence to divine command over practical considerations.

[i] This reflects the ancient belief that the human voice could have a beneficial effect on the preparation of sacred substances. This acoustic enhancement was considered part of the proper ritual technique for preparing the Temple incense.
[ii] The severity of this punishment—death for omitting even one ingredient—demonstrates the critical importance of the precise incense formula in Temple ritual. This parallels other capital offenses related to improper Temple service.
[iii] This detail about the accumulated leftovers (שִׁירַיִם) indicates careful conservation of the sacred substances over decades, reflecting both economic efficiency and ritual reverence for even small amounts of the sacred ingredients.
[iv] This hypothetical about honey enhancing the fragrance serves to emphasize that the prohibition against honey wasn't because it would diminish the incense quality, but rather because of the explicit biblical commandment, even though honey would have made the fragrance more potent.
[v] Cf. Keritot 6a — The Ma'avar Yabok is citing the original Talmudic source about proper incense preparation to establish the authoritative basis for the prayer that substitutes for the Temple incense offering. | Cf. Exodus 30:34-38 — This text elaborates on the biblical commandment regarding incense preparation, explaining technical details that weren't explicit in the Torah but were transmitted through rabbinic tradition. | Cf. Leviticus 2:11 — The passage explains the practical application of this biblical prohibition specifically to the incense preparation, showing how the general prohibition against honey in offerings applies to the specific case of the Temple incense.

יִשְׂרָאֵל[i] וְעַתָּה בֵּעָוֹנוֹתֵינוּ חָרַב
בֵּית הַמִּקְדָּשׁ וּבָטְלָה הָעֲבוֹדָה
וְאֵין לָנוּ לֹא כֹּהֵן וְלֹא מַחְתָּה
וְלֹא גַחֲלֵי אֵשׁ וְלֹא מִזְבֵּחַ וְלֹא
קְטֹרֶת הַסַּמִּים וְלֹא נִשְׁאַר לְפָנֵינוּ
אֶלָּא שִׂיחַ שִׂפְתוֹתֵינוּ[ii] שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר
וּנְשַׁלְּמָה פָרִים שְׂפָתֵינוּ. יְהִי
רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי
אֲבוֹתֵינוּ שֶׂיְּהֵא זִכָּרוֹן פִּינוּ מְקוּבָּל
לְפָנֶיךָ כְּמוֹ שֶׁהָיָה בְּאִלּוּ הִקְרַבְנוּ
לְפָנֶיךָ קְטוֹרֶת הַסַּמִּים וְתַעֲצוֹר
הַמַּגֵּפָה מֵעָלֵינוּ וּמֵעַל כָּל עַמְּךָ
יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּכָל הָאַרְצוֹת וּבְכָל
מְקוֹמוֹת מוֹשְׁבוֹתֵיהֶם כַּאֲשֶׁר
נֶעְצְרָה עַל יְדֵי אַהֲרֹן נְבִיא קְדוֹשֶׁךָ
יְיָ[iii] וְעָמוֹד מִכִּסֵּא דִּין וְשֶׁב עַל
כִּסֵּא רַחֲמִים[iv] וַחֲמוֹל עַל עַמְּךָ
יִשְׂרָאֵל וְעַל זְקֵנֵיהֶם וְעַל נְשֵׁיהֶם
וְעַל טַפֵּיהֶם וְעַל עוֹלָלֵיהֶם וְעַל
יוֹנְקֵיהֶם וְהָסֵר שָׂטָן מִלְּפָנֵינוּ
וּמֵאַחֲרֵינוּ[v] וְאַל תִּתֵּן הַמַּשְׁחִית
לָבֹא אֶל בָּתֵּינוּ לִנְגוֹף וְתַעֲצוֹר
אֶת הַדֶּבֶר וְאֶת הַמַּגֵּפָה וְאֶת
הַמַּשְׁחִית מֵעָלֵינוּ וּמֵעַל כָּל עַמְּךָ

ple has been destroyed and the service has ceased, and we have neither priest, nor fire-pan, nor coals of fire, nor altar, nor the aromatic incense. Nothing remains for us but the meditation of our lips, as it is said, "And let us offer the words of our lips instead of calves."[1] May it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers, that the remembrance of our speech be acceptable before Your throne of glory as if we had offered before You the aromatic incense. Stay the plague from us and from all Your people Israel in all lands and in all places of their dwelling, as it was stayed by the hand of Aaron, Your holy prophet.[2] Rise from the throne of judgment and sit upon the throne of mercy,[3] and have compassion upon Your people Israel, upon their elders, their wives, their children, their infants, and their sucklings. Remove the adversary from before us and from behind us,[4] and do not allow the destroyer to enter our houses to strike. Stay the pestilence, the plague, and the destroyer from us and from all Your people Israel. And so may it be Your will, LORD our God and God of our fathers, to eliminate from us and from Your people Israel pestilence, sword, famine, destroyer, and plague, and all kinds of evil diseases,

130 130R 135 135R 140 140R 145 145R 150

[1] This is a direct quote from Hosea 14:3, which became a foundational text for the rabbinic concept that prayer could substitute for Temple sacrifices after the destruction of the Temple. The Hebrew term 'parim' (פָּרִים) literally means 'bulls' or 'calves,' referring to animal sacrifices.

[2] This references the biblical episode in Numbers 17:11-13 where Aaron stopped a plague among the Israelites by offering incense. The text calls Aaron a 'prophet,' an unusual designation for him, perhaps to emphasize his sacred role in this protective ritual.

[3] This powerful imagery reflects kabbalistic concepts of divine attributes. God is portrayed as moving between two thrones representing different modes of divine governance: strict justice (din) and compassionate mercy (rachamim). This metaphor expresses the prayer's central request for God to shift from judgment to mercy.

[4] The 'adversary' (שָׂטָן/Satan) in Jewish mystical thought represents accusing or obstructing forces in the spiritual realms. The prayer envisions protection in all directions—from threats we can see coming ('before us') and from unexpected dangers ('behind us').

[i] The incense offering in the Temple served a dual purpose: creating a pleasant aroma in the sacred space and providing atonement. In kabbalistic thought, the ketoret (incense) was considered the most powerful of all Temple offerings, capable of uniting the upper and lower spiritual worlds.

[ii] This phrase, literally "the meditation of our lips," represents a core theological concept in post-Temple Judaism: that prayer and verbal recitation serve as spiritual substitutes for physical Temple offerings. This follows the principle established in Hosea 14:3.

[iii] This refers to the biblical episode in Numbers 17:11-13 where Aaron, at Moses' instruction, offered incense to stop a plague that had broken out among the Israelites. This story serves as the primary biblical proof-text for the protective power of the incense offering.

[iv] This imagery of God moving from a throne of judgment to a throne of mercy reflects a central kabbalistic concept of the divine shifting between attributes of judgment (din) and mercy (rachamim). This shift is seen as the goal of many prayer practices.

[v] The Satan here refers not merely to a personified adversary but to any accusing or obstructing force in the spiritual realms. In kabbalistic thought, the ketoret specifically had the power to neutralize these negative forces.

יִשְׂרָאֵל: וְכֵן יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ לְכָלּוֹת
מֵעָלֵינוּ וּמֵעַל עַמְּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל דֶּבֶר
וְחֶרֶב וְרָעָב וּמַשְׁחִית וּמַגֵּפָה וְכָל
155 מִינֵי תַחֲלוּאִים רָעִים וְכָל מִינֵי
פּוּרְעָנֻיּוֹת הַמִּתְרַגְּשׁוֹת וּבָאוֹת
לְעוֹלָם וּשְׁמוֹר תּוֹרָתְךָ וּשְׁמוֹר
צֵאתֵנוּ וּבוֹאֵנוּ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם
כִּי אַתָּה שׁוֹמֵר יִשְׂרָאֵל: יְיָ צְבָאוֹת
160 עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב
סֶלָה ג״פ:[i] יְיָ צְבָאוֹת אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם
בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ ג״פ: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ
יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ ג״פ: רְפָאֵנוּ
יְיָ וְנֵרָפֵא הוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה כִּי
165 תְהִלָּתֵנוּ אָתָּה: יְהִיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי
פִינוּ וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבֵּנוּ לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרֵנוּ
וְגוֹאֲלֵנוּ:[ii]

and all kinds of calamities that stir and come to the world. Protect Your Torah and protect our going out and our coming in from now and forever, for You are the Guardian of Israel. The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our stronghold, Selah. [3 times][1] LORD of hosts, happy is the person who trusts in You. [3 times] LORD, save! May the King answer us on the day we call. [3 times] Heal us, LORD, and we shall be healed; save us, and we shall be saved, for You are our praise.[2] May the words of our mouth and the meditation of our heart be acceptable before You, LORD, our Rock and our Redeemer. 150R 155R 160R

פרק ז׳

Chapter 7

ברוך הוא אשר בחר בעמו
ישראל המעוררים האהבה
מצד הימין בסוד ששים רבוא
דיוקנאות שבהם ובמיין נוקבין
5 שלהם מעוררים הזווג וכ״י
על ידם היא בתוקף אהבה עם
המלך ואומרת כל היקר הזה
ע״י צדיקים כנדרש בפ׳ נח

Blessed is He who chose His people Israel, who awaken love from the right side, through the secret of the sixty myriads of souls within them. Through their feminine waters they arouse the divine union, and the Community of Israel through them is in the fullness of love with the King.[3] She declares, "All this precious abundance comes through the righteous," as expounded in the portion of Noah 5R

[1] The Hebrew abbreviation ג״פ (gimmel-peh) indicates that the preceding verse should be recited three times. The threefold repetition of protective verses is a common practice in Jewish mystical traditions, believed to enhance their spiritual power.

[2] This concluding phrase from Jeremiah 17:14 reflects the prayer's theological foundation: that God is the ultimate source of healing and salvation, and that human praise and recognition of this fact is itself a form of spiritual connection that activates divine mercy.

[3] The 'King' here refers to God, particularly in His aspect as the divine masculine that unites with the feminine Shekhinah or Community of Israel.

[i] This abbreviation stands for "three times" (שלוש פעמים), indicating that the preceding verse should be recited three times. The threefold repetition of verses is a common practice in Jewish protective prayers, believed to enhance their spiritual efficacy.

[ii] Cf. Hosea 14:3 — This verse from Hosea is central to the prayer's theological argument that verbal recitation of the incense offering can serve as a spiritual substitute for the actual Temple ritual that is no longer possible. | Cf. Numbers 17:11-13 — The prayer refers to how Aaron's incense offering stopped a plague, drawing directly from this biblical episode to argue for the efficacy of the incense formula as a protective measure against disease. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4 — This prayer builds on the book's earlier theological explanations of how the incense offering (ketoret) specifically has power to ward off plagues and harmful spiritual forces. | Cf. Psalm 46:8,12 — This verse is incorporated as a protective formula to be recited three times, reflecting the Jewish mystical belief in the protective power of scriptural verses, particularly when repeated in groups of three. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This quotation from Jeremiah connects the spiritual protection of the incense with physical healing, reinforcing the prayer's dual focus on spiritual and physical well-being.

ובפ׳ אמור באינון דמקשטין לקדושה בליל שבועות ואהבה היא בהיותה מחובקת מדודה שמאלו תחת לראשי וגו׳ וע״י נשמותיהן מתעורר שפע מג׳ בחינות על ידי הלוים מהשמאל ע״י ישראל מהאמצעי ע״י הכהנים מימין וזהו וקרבתנו מלכנו לשמך הגדול וביחוד בינה תפארת ומלכות בסוד ג׳ שמותיהם משולבים יחד. שמשם שרשי נשמות צדיקים מיד ביטול הקליפות וכל ההויה הכשרות נשלף להם נשמה רוחנית חיונית טהורה דרך פתח היכל לבנת הספיר וזהו בחצות הלילה כי שער זה נפתח והחיים העליונים מתפשטים בכל הנבראים. ע״כ אשרי אדם מצא חכמה ולבו יפיק תבונה לכוין מעשיו לעורר החיות עליון עליו ועל הנלוים עליו ויהי לעולם דעתו קשור בהרהור תורה ובזה מיחד הדעת במלכות בבחינתה שהיא עטרת בעלה למעלה מחסד וגבורה וזהו מצות והיו הדברים האלה על לבבך שלא תפרד דעתך מהם רגע. עוד ישתדל להשפיע מתורתו לבניו ולתלמידיו ובזה מיחד מלכות עם ת״ת בבחינתה שלמעלה מנצח והוד כיהם נקרא בנים שנאמר וכל בניך למודי ה׳ והיינו מצות ושננתם לבניך. עוד צריך שיהיה האדם לומד לבדו ובזה השכינה מתייחדת עמו ותורה לשמה מוריד הת״ת למלכות בבחינתה למטה וזהו מצות ודברת בם. עוד ישתדל שתהיה שמירת המלכות עמו וזה אינו זמן יחוד בתפלה ותורה אלא בעסקיו וצרכי גוויתו אז השכינה שהיא שמירת הדרך תהיה עמו לשומרו אם ישא ויתן באמונה וישים אליה לבו וזהו

and the portion of Emor, regarding those who adorn themselves for holiness on the night of Shavuot. And love flourishes when she is embraced by her beloved, as in "His left hand is under my head, etc." Through their souls, divine influx is awakened from three aspects: through the Levites from the left, through Israel from the center, and through the priests from the right.[1] This is the meaning of "You have brought us near, our King, to Your great Name," especially through the unification of Binah, Tiferet, and Malkhut, in the secret of their three names interwoven together.[2]

From there flow the roots of righteous souls, immediately nullifying the negative forces. For all worthy beings, a pure spiritual vital soul is drawn down to them through the entrance of the Palace of the Sapphire Brick. This occurs at midnight, when this gate opens and the supernal life-forces extend to all created beings. Therefore, fortunate is the person who finds wisdom and whose heart produces understanding, directing his actions to awaken the supernal vitality upon himself and those connected to him. Let his mind always be bound in contemplation of Torah, thereby unifying Da'at (Knowledge) with Malkhut in its aspect as "crown of her husband," which is above Chesed and Gevurah. This is the commandment, "These words shall be upon your heart"—that your mind should not be separated from them for a moment.

Furthermore, one should strive to share his Torah with his children and students, thereby unifying Malkhut with Tiferet in its aspect above Netzach and Hod, for they are called "children," as it is said, "And all your children shall be taught of the Lord"—this is the commandment, "You shall teach them diligently to your children." One must also study Torah alone, through which the Divine Presence unites with him, and Torah studied for its own sake brings down Tiferet to Malkhut in its lower aspect. This is the commandment, "You shall speak of them."

One should also ensure that the protection of Malkhut accompanies him. This is not the time of unification through prayer and Torah study, but

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding of the three biblical divisions of the Jewish people (Priests, Levites, and Israelites) as corresponding to different divine attributes and cosmic channels.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic practice of unifying different divine names to create cosmic harmonization and spiritual power.

מצות ובלכתך בדרך. עוד חייב לתקן תקוני שבינה בבחינת היות
55 סוכת דוד הנופלת בהצטער על חרבן ביתה והיכלה. וזהו ובשכבך ובזה יזכה להשלים תקוניה בסוד הגאולה כשיהיה אור הלבנה כאור החמה וזהו
60 ובקומך בסוד קומי אורי כי בא אורך ובזה יקיים בכל דרכיך דעהו והוא יישר אורחותיך ועושה צדקה בכל עת ויזכה לסוד ויעש דוד שם כדפי׳ בפ׳
65 בהר סיני. ותמיד יוסיף שמן לנר מאור שבינת אל על ראשו ואל יגרום סלוקה ח״ו במעשיו וירחיק עצמו מכל נדנוד עבירה ובפרט מן השקרים. ואמרו
70 בתקון ס״ע דף ק״ט ומאן גרים דלא שרייא שבינתא עליה דאדם ולא נהיר שמשא עליה בגין הבל דשקרא ומלין דשקרא נפקין מפומי׳ אית הבל ממארי דשקרא
75 דאתמר בהון הבל המה מעשה תעתועים ואית הבל דאתמר ביה על כל מוצא פי ה׳ יחיה האדם ודא הבל דאורייתא דאינון חמשה חומשי תורה מן
80 בית דבראשית עד למ״ד דלעיני כל ישראל. ודא הוא הב״ל. הנה כי מות וחיים ביד לשון ואל יתפתה בנוקבא דס״מ דנחש אקרי ואשת זנונים וקץ כל
85 בשר וקץ הימים דקשיטת גרמה בבמה תכשיטין בזונה וקיימא בריש ארחין ושבילין לפתאה בני נשא. שטיא דקריב בהדה אתקיפת ביה נשקת ליה מסכת
90 ליה חמרא דורדייא ומרורת פתנים כיון דשתי אסטי אבתרה לבתר דחמת ליה סטי מאורחא דקשוט אבתרה אפשיטת גרמה מכל אינון תקונין דהות מתתקנא
95 לגבי דההוא שטיא תקונין דילה

rather during his business affairs and bodily needs. Then the Divine Presence, which is the guardian of the way, will be with him to protect him if he con- 55R
ducts his business honestly and directs his heart toward Her. This is the commandment, "When you walk by the way."

Furthermore, one is obligated to rectify the Divine Presence in her aspect as "the fallen booth of 60R
David," by grieving over the destruction of Her house and palace. This is the meaning of "when you lie down." Through this, one merits to complete Her rectification in the mystery of redemption, when "the
light of the moon shall be as the light of the sun." 65R
This is the meaning of "when you rise up," alluding to "Arise, shine, for your light has come." In this way, one fulfills "In all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make straight your paths," performing
righteousness at all times and meriting the secret of 70R
"And David made a name for himself," as explained in the portion of Behar Sinai.

One should always add oil to the lamp of God's Presence shining upon his head, and not cause its re-
moval, heaven forbid, through his actions. He should 75R
distance himself from any hint of transgression, especially from falsehoods. As stated in Tikkun 70, page 109: "What causes the Divine Presence not to rest upon a person and the sun not to shine upon him?
The breath of falsehood and words of lies that come 80R
from his mouth." There is the breath of masters of falsehood, of whom it is said, "They are vanity, a work of delusion," and there is the breath of which it is said, "By every word that proceeds from the
mouth of God shall man live"—this is the breath of 85R
Torah, which comprises the five books of the Torah from the bet of "Bereshit" to the lamed of "before all Israel."[1] This is the HaBe"L[2] (breath/vanity). Indeed, death and life are in the power of the tongue.

One should not be seduced by the female aspect 90R
of Samael, who is called the serpent, the wife of harlotry, the end of all flesh, and the end of days. She adorns herself with many ornaments like a harlot and stands at the head of paths and byways to entice
people. The fool who approaches her—she seizes 95R

[1]This refers to the entirety of the Torah, from its first letter (bet in 'Bereshit'/Genesis) to its last letter (lamed in 'le'einei kol Yisrael'/before all Israel, the final words of Deuteronomy).
[2]The Hebrew word הבל (hevel) means 'breath' or 'vanity' and appears prominently in Ecclesiastes. Here it's given a positive interpretation through its connection to Torah study, and the letters are capitalized to indicate it's being treated as an acronym.

שערה מתקנין סומקן כוורדא
אנפהא חיוורין וסומקין וכו׳
פיה מתתקנא בפתיחו דקיק יאה
בתקונה. לישנא חדידא כחרבא
שיעין מילאה כמשחא שפוותא
יאן סומקין כוורדא מתיקן בכל
מתיקו דעלמא ארגוונא לבשת
אתתקנת בארבעין תקונין חסר
חד. מניין ל״ט שהוא תרגום
של ארור וכן גרמה ל״ט קללות
לעולם בחטא הקדום וכל זה
משל לכמה עבירות המפתה
בהם בני אדם. שטיא דאסטי
אבתרהא ושתי מכסא דחמרא
ועביד בה נאופין ואסטי אבתרה
מה עבדת שבקת ליה נאים
בערסא סליקת לעילא ואלשינת
עליה ונעלא רשות ונתתא אתער
ההוא שטיא ותשב לחייכא בהדא
בבקדמיתא והיא אעדיאת תקונה
מינה ואתהדרת גובר תקוף
קאים לקבליה לביש לבושא
דנורא מלהטא בדחילו תקוף
מרתתא נפשא וגופא ערומא
מלייא דעיינין דחלן חרבא
שננא בידה טיפין מרירין תליין
מההוא חרבא קטיל ליה לההוא
שטיא וארמי ליה לגו גיהנם.
כמה הלכתא גברוותא איכא
למילף מדברי המאמר הזה
למאן דלא נאים ושכיב לשמור
עצמו מאשה זרה מנכריה אמריה
החליקה ואל יכלה ימיו בהבל
וריק אחרי עצתה כי הזמן יקר
שבנמצאות. ואמרו במדרש כי
הבל גבר על קין וחמל עליו
משום דברי תחנונים שאמר לו
וכשהניחו הבל קם קין והרגו
כי כן הוא דרך החצונים כי
כשאין להם מעשים למטה נעשים
רשים ותחתונים ידברו לנוכח
הקדושה להתפרנס והקב״ה
חומל עליהם בחנם ומשפיעם
וגם רשע ליום רעה. אמנם
כאשר יגברו הגבורות לסבת עון
והם בשדה אחר שהיא מלכות
המתעוררת מדיני הגבורות מיד
ויקם קין אל הבל שהוא סוד

him, kisses him, and mixes for him wine of dregs and venom of serpents. Once he drinks, he follows after her. When she sees him deviating from the path of truth to follow her, she strips herself of all those adornments with which she had adorned herself for that fool. Her adornments include her hair arranged red like a rose, her face white and red, etc., her mouth arranged with a delicate opening, beautiful in its form, her tongue sharp as a sword, her words smooth as oil, her lips beautiful, red as a rose, sweetened with all the sweetness of the world, dressed in purple, adorned with thirty-nine ornaments. The number thirty-nine is the numerical value of "cursed" in Aramaic, and thus she caused thirty-nine curses to the world through the primordial sin. All this is an allegory for the many transgressions with which she entices people.

The fool who strays after her and drinks from the cup of wine, commits adultery with her and follows her—what does she do? She leaves him sleeping in his bed, ascends above, slanders him, and locks the gate from above. When that fool awakens, she returns to laugh with him as before, but she removes her adornments and transforms into a mighty warrior standing against him, wearing flaming garments, inspiring terror, causing his soul and naked body to tremble. She is full of fearsome eyes, a sharpened sword in her hand, bitter drops hanging from that sword. She slays that fool and casts him into Gehenna. How many significant laws can be learned from this discourse for one who is not asleep but alert to guard himself from the strange woman, from the foreign woman whose words are smooth! One should not waste his days in vanity and emptiness following her counsel, for time is the most precious of all things.

It is said in the Midrash that Abel prevailed over Cain and had mercy on him because of the words of supplication that he said to him. But when Abel released him, Cain arose and killed him. For such is the way of the external forces: when they have no deeds below, they become poor and speak supplications before holiness to receive sustenance, and the Holy One, blessed be He, has mercy on them freely and sustains them—"even the wicked for the day of evil." However, when the powers of judgment strengthen due to sin, and they are in "another field," which is Malkhut aroused by the judgments of Gevu-

מטטרו״ן אחיו ודמי עץ הדעת
145 טוב ורע ויהרגהו כי מכבה אור
הקדושה בהיותו מעורר הדינים
ואין חומל כלל. ואמרו בפ׳
ויחי ווי למאן דגרע יומוהי לעיל
ווי ליה ווי לנפשיה זכאין אינון
150 צדיקייא. אשרי הגדל בשם טוב
ונפטר בשם טוב. אלהים יעזרנו
לעשות רצונו בעה״ז ובעה״ב עם
כל ישראל גאולים ואנחנו נבר״ך
י״ה ובית אהרן ברכו את ה׳: [i]

rah, immediately "Cain rose up against Abel," who
represents the mystery of Metatron his brother and 145R
the "blood of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and
Evil," and killed him, for he extinguishes the light of
holiness by arousing judgments, showing no mercy
at all.

And they said in the portion of Vayechi: "Woe 150R
to one who diminishes his days above;[1] woe to him,
woe to his soul! Fortunate are the righteous." Happy
is one who grows up with a good name and departs
with a good name. May God help us to do His will in
this world and in the World to Come, with all Israel 155R
redeemed, and we shall bless the Lord, and the house
of Aaron, bless the Lord.

פרק ח׳

Chapter 8

ראיתי להביא פה שכר איזה
מצות אשר יעשה אותם האדם
וחי בהם לחיי עד כפי הנמצא
בתקונים אשר מהם אזן תבחן
5 כמה גדול שכר של עושי מצוה
לפני הקדוש ברוך הוא. אמרו
בתקון ע׳ [ii] כי המלך הקדוש

I have seen fit to present here the reward for certain
commandments that a person performs and lives by
them for eternal life, according to what is found in
the Tikkunim [Tikkunei Zohar], from which the ear
can discern how great is the reward of those who per- 5R
form commandments before the Holy One, blessed
be He. They said in Tikkun 70 that for one who

[1] In kabbalistic thought, one's actions in this world correspond to cosmic realities in higher worlds. This phrase suggests that wasting time or engaging in sin actually diminishes one's spiritual lifespan in higher realms.

[i] Cf. Song of Songs 2:6 — The author uses this verse to illustrate the divine embrace between God and the Community of Israel (Knesset Yisrael), a common kabbalistic interpretation of Song of Songs as representing the love between the divine masculine and feminine aspects. | Cf. Isaiah 60:1 — This reference to Isaiah connects the redemptive awakening of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) with the biblical prophecy of Israel's restoration, suggesting that proper spiritual practice contributes to cosmic redemption. | Cf. Proverbs 3:6 — This verse is cited to emphasize that divine consciousness should permeate all aspects of life, not just formal religious practice. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:6-7 — The author reinterprets the Shema prayer as instructions for maintaining constant divine unification through Torah study and teaching, giving these familiar verses a kabbalistic interpretation. | Cf. Isaiah 54:13 — This verse is used to support the idea that spiritual students are considered 'children' in a mystical sense, and teaching Torah creates unifications in the divine realms. | Cf. Amos 9:11 — This reference to the 'fallen booth of David' (sukkat David ha-nofelet) represents the Shekhinah in exile, suggesting that personal spiritual practice helps rectify this cosmic condition. | Cf. Isaiah 30:26 — This prophetic image is used to describe the future redemptive state when the Shekhinah (associated with the moon) will be restored to full glory, equivalent to Tiferet (associated with the sun). | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar 70 — This reference to the Tikkunei Zohar explicitly connects falsehood with the departure of divine presence, emphasizing the importance of truthfulness in maintaining spiritual connection. | Cf. Jeremiah 10:15 — This biblical reference is used to characterize negative speech as empty delusion, contrasting it with the life-giving power of divine speech. | Cf. Deuteronomy 8:3 — This verse is repurposed to contrast the destructive 'breath' of falsehood with the life-giving 'breath' of Torah study and divine speech. | Cf. Zohar, Vayechi — This Zoharic reference emphasizes the cosmic consequences of wasting time, suggesting that improper use of time affects one's spiritual destiny.

[ii] This refers to Tikkun 70 of the Tikkunei Zohar, a kabbalistic text composed in the 13th century that consists of 70 interpretations of the first word of the Torah.

ברוך הוא על כל אבר ואבר אין סוף למתן שכרו והאריך שם הרבה בזה יע״ש וזו תהיה כוונת האדם בה׳ אחד[i] ולכלול עצמו ביחוד באשר דרשנו בח״ב. המתעטף בציצית ומניח תפילין וקורא קריאת שמע[ii] מתקן כסא בעטוף מצוה דכתיב והוכן בחסד כסא ובתפילין הוא מעטר לו וקורא השירה על הכסא שמע ישראל כמו כן הקדוש ברוך הוא מתקן לו בעולם ההוא כסא ועטרה ועיין מזה גם כן בתקונים החדשים[iii] דף ק״מ ע״ב ובדף קמ״א מדבר בחלוקי עונשי הנפשות כפי מעשיהם. וכמו שהאדם מוריד היושב על הכסא בכסאו וקם לכבודו וממליך אותו על כל אבר מאבריו כן הקדוש ברוך הוא ממליכו על כל מפנות ומלאכים ששם דכתיב כי מכבדי אכבד. וכמו שהאדם מנגן לפני הקב״ה בכמה נגונים משירות ותשבחות והודאות כמו כן כשעולה למעלה כל פמליא של מעלה כל החוות כל המרכבות ומחנות מלאכים קדושים דחיות ואופנים ושרפים[iv] פורשים כנפיהם בשמחה ובנגון לקבלו זהו שכר המתפללים:[v]

enthrones the Holy One, blessed be He, over each and every limb, there is no end to his reward, and it elaborates greatly on this there—see it for yourself. This should be a person's intention in [declaring] "the Lord is One," and to include oneself in this unification, as we have expounded in Part Two. 10R

One who wraps himself in tzitzit, puts on tefillin, and recites the Shema prepares a throne through the wrapping of the commandment, as it is written, "And the throne will be established through kindness." With the tefillin, he crowns Him, and recites the song upon the throne: "Hear, O Israel." Likewise, the Holy One, blessed be He, prepares for him in that world [the World to Come] a throne and a crown. See also regarding this in the New Tikkunim, page 140b, and on page 141 it discusses the different punishments of souls according to their deeds. 15R 20R

Just as a person causes the One who sits on the throne to descend to his throne, and rises in His honor, and enthrones Him over each of his limbs, so too the Holy One, blessed be He, enthrones him over all the celestial corners and angels that are there, as it is written, "For those who honor Me, I will honor." And just as a person makes music before the Holy One, blessed be He, with various melodies of songs, praises, and thanksgivings, similarly, when he ascends above, the entire heavenly entourage—all the celestial creatures, all the divine chariots, and the camps of holy angels, the living creatures, the wheels, and the seraphim—spread their wings with joy and melody to receive him. This is the reward of those who pray." 25R 30R 35R

[i] The phrase 'ה׳ אחד' (the Lord is One) refers to the central declaration of the Shema prayer: 'Hear O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is One.'

[ii] These three ritual actions—wrapping in tzitzit (ritual fringes), donning tefillin (phylacteries), and reciting the Shema—are fundamental morning prayers in Jewish practice, described here as creating a mystical effect in the upper worlds.

[iii] The 'New Tikkunim' likely refers to later additions to or commentaries on the Tikkunei Zohar, possibly the work known as 'Tikkunim Chadashim' that expanded on the original 70 Tikkunim.

[iv] This describes the celestial hierarchy of angels based on Ezekiel's vision and rabbinic elaborations, including the divine entourage, the celestial creatures, divine chariots, angelic camps, Chayot, Ofanim, and Seraphim—each representing different levels of angelic beings.

[v] Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author cites Tikkun 70 from the Tikkunei Zohar as a primary source for his discussion of divine rewards for those who properly perform commandments with the right intention. | Cf. New Tikkunim — The author refers to a text called 'New Tikkunim' (possibly later additions to or commentaries on the Tikkunei Zohar) to provide further information about divine rewards and punishments. | Cf. 1 Samuel 2:30 — The author uses this biblical verse to support the idea that God responds to human devotion with corresponding honor and elevation in the celestial realms. | Cf. Proverbs 16:12 — The author uses this verse to explain how performing commandments (specifically wrapping in tzitzit) creates a metaphysical throne through acts of kindness. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author refers back to his own earlier exposition in Part Two of Ma'avar Yabok regarding the proper intention during prayer and unification with the divine,

טוב הצפן למוהלים[i][ii] The Good Reserved for Circumcisers[1] 40R

כמו שהמל מעביר מאבר הברית של יהודי בחתיכתו הערלה ובפריעה[iii] ומתקן שם מקום להשרות שם השכינה כן כשנשמתו תעלה למעלה הקדוש ברוך הוא יעביר ממנה כל מלאכי חבלה ומקטרגים שלא יקרבו אליה משום ששם ה׳ שורה עליו הנרמז במי״ יעלה״ לנו״ השמימה״ בשם ה׳ עולה למעלה השמימה נשמתו[iv] ויתקיים בו אז וראו כי שם ה׳ נקרא עליך וגו׳. כמו שהאדם מקבל עליו כל מצות עשה ביראה ואהבה כמו כן ממליכין אותו החיילות ומחנות של העולמות שתקן לו הקדוש ברוך הוא למעלה ומקבלים אותו עליהם ביראה ואהבה. וכשאדם עוסק בתורה ובמצות שהם נר כאלו מאיר בעמוד האמצעי[v] ביום לפני ה׳ ועמוד האש לילה כן בשהולך

Just as one who performs circumcision removes the foreskin[2] from the covenant organ of a Jew and exposes the corona, thereby preparing a place for the Divine Presence to dwell there, similarly when his soul ascends on high, the Holy One, blessed be He, 45R will remove from it all destructive angels and accusers so they cannot approach it, because the Name of the Lord rests upon him. This is alluded to in "Who shall ascend for us to heaven,"[3] for in the Name of the Lord his soul ascends upward to heaven, 50R and then will be fulfilled in him "and they shall see that the Name of the Lord is called upon you, etc."

Just as a person accepts all positive commandments with reverence and love, likewise the hosts and camps of the worlds that the Holy One, blessed be 55R He, has prepared for him above will crown him as their king and accept him with reverence and love. And when a person engages in Torah and commandments, which are like a lamp, it is as if he illuminates the central pillar by day before the Lord[4] and the 60R pillar of fire by night. So too, when he goes to that world, it is written about him, "And the Lord went

[1] This is a section heading introducing the spiritual rewards that await those who perform the ritual of circumcision (mohels). In Jewish mystical thought, those who perform sacred rituals like circumcision accumulate special merit that protects them in both this world and the next.

[2] The opening metaphor compares ritual circumcision to the spiritual protection afforded to the soul after death. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that physical rituals create corresponding spiritual realities.

[3] This refers to a mystical interpretation where the initial letters of the Hebrew phrase "mi ya'aleh lanu hashamaimah" (מי יעלה לנו השמימה) form the word "milah" (מילה), meaning circumcision, creating a connection between circumcision and heavenly ascent.

[4] The "central pillar" (amud ha-emtza'i) refers to Tiferet, the central sefirah in Kabbalah that balances mercy and judgment. The passage draws parallels between Torah study and the pillars of cloud and fire that guided the Israelites in the wilderness.

creating continuity within the larger work.

[i] This title heading introduces a section specifically addressing the spiritual rewards and protection granted to mohels (ritual circumcisers). The phrase can be understood as "The good that is stored up/hidden away for those who perform circumcisions."

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section 2, Chapter 130 — The author creates a thematic connection between the rewards for those who circumcise and other sections of the work discussing spiritual rewards for sacred actions. This section elaborates on the mystical benefits that accrue to mohels (ritual circumcisers).

[iii] The text begins with circumcision as a metaphor for spiritual purification and protection. In Jewish law, circumcision involves two steps: milah (cutting the foreskin) and periah (exposing the corona), both mentioned here.

[iv] This refers to a mystical interpretation of Deuteronomy 30:12. The Hebrew phrase "mi ya'aleh lanu hashamaimah" (who shall ascend to heaven for us) contains an acronym for "milah" (circumcision), suggesting that circumcision facilitates the soul's ascent to heaven.

[v] The "central pillar" (amuda d'emtza'ita) is a kabbalistic reference to Tiferet, the central sefirah that balances mercy and judgment. Torah study is understood to illuminate this divine attribute.

לאותו העולם כתוב בו וה׳
הולך לפניהם יומם בעמוד ענן
לנחותם הדרך ולילה בעמוד
אש להאיר להם למי לנפש ורוח
ונשמה שלו שהם נגד כהן לוי
ישראל.[i] וכל השומר שבת ומכבד
אותו ומענג אותו כדי לכבד
הקדוש ברוך הוא כמו כן הקדוש
ברוך הוא נותן לו מקום למעלה
במנוחה שאנן והשקט שלא טרח
בו ונח שם מכל הטורח שטרח
בעולם הזה במעשיו. ויש מצות
תלויות בדיוקן המלך דיש בפנים
ויש בעיינין וכן בכל בחינה
ובחינה ומכל אחד מתפרשים
כמה חיילות ומחנות ממלאכים.
וכל נימא ונימא הוא מלאך
התלוי בראש[ii] ויש ממלאכים
אלו שנקראו אזני ה׳ עיני ה׳
וכן בכל שאר כנויי האברים
וכשעולה הנשמה כל חיילות אלו
עולות עמה וכשיורדת יורדים
עמה וכשעולה קול יורד מרום
רקיעים לכל חיילות ומחנות
תנו כבוד לדיוקן המלך. ובכל
יום צריך לעשות צד״קה לענות
תשעים אמנים ד׳ קדושות מאה
ברכות[iii] חמשה חומשי תורה
ויש אומרים ה׳ קדישים ובחינת
צדקה באימא עילאה וצדק
אימא תתאה דכתיב צדק לפניו

before them by day in a pillar of cloud to guide them on the way, and by night in a pillar of fire to give them light"—to whom? To his nefesh, ruach, and neshamah, which correspond to Kohen, Levi, and Israelite.[1] 65R

One who observes the Sabbath, honors it, and delights in it in order to honor the Holy One, blessed be He—similarly, the Holy One, blessed be He, gives him a place above in tranquil and peaceful rest where he has not labored, and he rests there from all the labor he exerted in this world through his deeds. There are commandments that depend on the King's image—some in the face, some in the eyes, and so in every aspect—and from each one are derived numerous hosts and camps of angels. Each hair is an angel hanging from the head, and among these angels are those called "the ears of the Lord," "the eyes of the Lord," and so with all other bodily designations. When the soul ascends, all these hosts ascend with it, and when it descends, they descend with it. And when it ascends, a voice descends from the heights of the firmaments to all the hosts and camps: "Give honor to the image of the King!" 70R 75R 80R 85R

Every day one must perform charity, respond to ninety Amens, four Kedushahs, one hundred blessings, and [study] the five books of the Torah. Some say five Kaddishes.[2] The attribute of Tzedakah (charity) corresponds to the supernal Mother,[3] and Tzedek (righteousness) to the lower Mother, as it is written "Righteousness goes before Him." With each of one's limbs, one should be 90R

[1] This presents a kabbalistic correspondence system where the three levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) align with the three divisions of the Jewish people, representing ascending levels of holiness and spiritual function.

[2] The text presents a daily spiritual regimen that includes responding to 90 Amens, 4 Kedushahs, and reciting 100 blessings, along with studying Torah. These numerical values have mystical significance in kabbalistic practice.

[3] This presents a kabbalistic correspondence where tzedakah (charity) is associated with Binah (the "supernal Mother") while tzedek (righteousness) is associated with Malkhut (the "lower Mother"). This reflects the kabbalistic understanding of two feminine divine attributes.

[i] This is a kabbalistic correspondence: the three levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) are associated with the three divisions of the Jewish people (Israelite, Levi, Kohen), representing ascending levels of holiness.

[ii] This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that each hair is connected to spiritual channels (tzinnorot) and has an angelic counterpart. This concept appears in the Zohar and is used to explain why some Jewish practices involve covering or not cutting hair.

[iii] This refers to specific daily spiritual practices: responding to 90 instances of "Amen," reciting 4 Kedushah prayers, and making 100 blessings. These numbers have mystical significance in kabbalistic tradition.

יהלך[i] ובכל אחד מאבריו צריך להזדרז לעשות מצוה דבכל אחד
95 אית מלאכין דתליין בהו ומיקרין אותו בצאתו מן העולם. המיחד לקודשא בריך הוא ושכינתיה בעולם הזה הקדוש ברוך הוא מזווג אותו בבת זוגו לעה״ב.
100 המקריב לשבינה קרבן לה׳ בעוה״ז קב״ה מזווג אותו בדת זווג לעולם הבא. העושה מקדש מעט בית הכנסת בעולם הזה הקדוש ברוך הוא עושה לו בית
105 לדור בו בעולם הבא שהוא קדש קדשים. העושה סוכה להקדוש ברוך הוא. מסכך עליו בעולם ההוא ומגין עליו מכל מלאכי חבלה ביציאתו מן העולם. וכל
110 המברך להקדוש ברוך הוא ומקדש אותו בעולם הזה הקדוש ברוך הוא מברך ומקדש אותו בעולם ההוא. וכמו שאין קדושה בפחות מעשרה כן הקדוש ברוך
115 הוא עושה לו עשרה חופות בגן עדן. קדושין דקודשא בריך הוא עם שבינתיה הם קדוש קדוש קדוש שבע ברכות שלו הם בקריאת שמע בשחר ובערב
120 ויחודו שמע ישראל כן הקדוש ברוך הוא מברך אותו ולכלה שלו ומקדש שלו עמה בקדוש ומיחד שניהם והכל מדה כנגד מדה סוף סוף כל מה שמשתדל
125 אדם במצותיו של הקדוש ברוך הוא בגינו ובגין שכינתיה כמו כן משתדל הקדוש ברוך הוא בגינו ובגין בת זוגו בעולם ההיא אשרי המשתדל לעשות רצון קונו הוא
130 עושה רצונו לפי שעה בעולם. הזה ובונה לו בנין כן הקדוש ברוך הוא בונה לאדם בעולמו בנין לדורי דורות. וצריך שלא יהיה שום אחד מאבריו פנוי משם

diligent to perform a commandment, for with each limb there are angels that depend on it, and they honor him when he departs from the world. 95R

One who unifies the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence in this world—the Holy One, blessed be He, unites him with his soulmate in the World to Come. One who offers the Divine Presence as a sacrifice to the Lord in this world—the Holy One, blessed be He, unites him in sacred union in the World to Come. One who builds a small sanctuary, a synagogue, in this world—the Holy One, blessed be He, builds him a house to dwell in the World to Come, which is the Holy of Holies. One who makes a sukkah for the Holy One, blessed be He—He covers him in that world and protects him from all destructive angels when he departs from the world. And anyone who blesses the Holy One, blessed be He, and sanctifies Him in this world—the Holy One, blessed be He, blesses and sanctifies him in that world. 100R 105R 110R

Just as there is no sanctification with fewer than ten, so too the Holy One, blessed be He, makes for him ten canopies in the Garden of Eden. The sanctification of the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence is "Holy, Holy, Holy"; His seven blessings are in the recitation of the Shema morning and evening,[1] and His unification is "Hear, O Israel." So too, the Holy One, blessed be He, blesses him and his bride, and sanctifies them together with holiness, and unifies them both—all measure for measure. Ultimately, all that a person strives to do in the commandments of the Holy One, blessed be He, for His sake and for the sake of His Divine Presence—likewise the Holy One, blessed be He, strives for his sake and for the sake of his soulmate in that world. Happy is he who strives to do the will of his Creator—he does His will for a time in this world and builds a building for himself, so too the Holy One, blessed be He, builds for the person in His world a building for all generations. 115R 120R 125R 130R

One must ensure that none of his limbs is devoid of the Name YHVH, and one should enthrone Him in every limb and organ until they are all complete 135R

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic understanding of the Shema prayer as containing mystical unifications of divine names and attributes, parallel to the seven marriage blessings (sheva berakhot).

[i] This connects the concept of "tzedek" (righteousness) with the "lower Mother" (Malkhut), contrasted with "tzedakah" (charity) connected to the "supernal Mother" (Binah). This reflects the kabbalistic understanding of two feminine divine attributes.

הוי״ה ולהמליך אותו בכל אבר ואבר עד שיהיו כלם שלמים בדיוקן הקב״ה שאם חסר אחד מהם אינו בצלמו של הקב״ה. וישרה נשמתו בלבו דאז היא נקראת מטרוניתא[i] ולא יורידנה משם חס ושלום לרגליו אלא יהיה עטור השכינה תמיד על ראשו כנתן דצוציתא ואז יראה אור כי יהל ברוך המאיר לארץ ולדרים:[ii]

in the image of the Holy One, blessed be He, for if one of them is missing, he is not in the image of the Holy One, blessed be He. His soul should dwell in his heart, for then it is called a Queen,[1] and he should not, God forbid, lower it to his feet. Rather, the crown of the Divine Presence should always be upon his head like one who wears tassels, and then he will see light as it shines—blessed is He who gives light to the earth and those who dwell upon it.

140R

נשלם חלק ראשון ממאמר רביעי הנקרא עתר ענן הקטרת[iii iv]

The first part of the fourth discourse, called "Eter Anan HaKetoret" [Cloud of Incense Prayer[2]], is com-

145R

[1] "Queen" (matronita) is a kabbalistic term for the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). The text suggests that when the soul properly dwells in the heart, it takes on this elevated status, connecting to the divine feminine aspect.

[2] The title 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' combines three Hebrew terms: 'eter' (prayer/supplication),

[i] "Matronita" (Queen) is a kabbalistic term for the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). The text suggests that when one's soul properly dwells in the heart, it takes on this elevated status, connecting to the divine feminine aspect.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The passage draws heavily on Zoharic concepts of divine unification, correspondence between human and divine realms, and the cosmic significance of ritual actions. The text employs typical Zoharic imagery of the divine feminine (Shekhinah), pillars of cloud and fire, and the rewards in the supernal realms. | Cf. Genesis 1:26-27 — The text reinterprets the biblical concept of divine image (tzelem Elohim) through a kabbalistic lens, suggesting that each human limb corresponds to divine attributes and names, and that maintaining the integrity of all limbs with proper spiritual intentions preserves one's status as being in God's image. | Cf. Exodus 13:21-22 — The text reinterprets the biblical narrative of divine guidance in the wilderness as a metaphor for spiritual illumination. Just as God guided Israel with pillars of cloud and fire, engagement with Torah and mitzvot creates spiritual light that guides the different components of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) in both this world and the next. | Cf. Deuteronomy 28:10 — The text reinterprets this verse, originally about Israel's distinct status among nations, to describe the spiritual protection afforded to individual souls that have been properly prepared through mitzvot. The divine name provides protection against accusers and harmful spiritual forces. | Cf. Mishnah Megillah 4:3 — The text creates a mystical correspondence between the halakhic requirement for a minyan in this world and the reward of ten canopies in the Garden of Eden, demonstrating how earthly ritual requirements have direct spiritual parallels in the afterlife. | Cf. Isaiah 58:13-14 — The text builds on the biblical promise that those who honor the Sabbath will 'delight in the Lord,' expanding this into a more specific mystical reward of a place of peaceful rest in the higher realms, suggesting a measure-for-measure correspondence between Sabbath rest in this world and eternal rest in the next.

[iii] This formal closing statement marks the end of the first part of the fourth discourse. In traditional Hebrew manuscripts and books, such statements serve as structural markers that help readers navigate the text. The phrase 'נשלם' (completed) is commonly used to indicate the conclusion of a major section.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Fourth Discourse — This line marks the formal conclusion of the first part of the fourth discourse of Ma'avar Yabok. 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer) is the title of this section, which focuses on prayer as a spiritual substitute for the Temple incense offerings. As seen in the context, this section explores how proper recitation of the Ketoret (incense) formula creates metaphysical effects similar to the actual Temple service. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Structural Organization — This concluding statement reflects the meticulous structural organization of Ma'avar Yabok, where the author Aaron Berechia of Modena divided his work into distinct discourses (ma'amarim), with each discourse further divided into parts. The work consistently uses these formal closing statements to mark the end of major sections, helping readers navigate the complex text.

pleted.

'anan' (cloud), and 'ketoret' (incense). This richly metaphorical title evokes the imagery of prayer rising like incense smoke, drawing on the biblical concept that prayers ascend to heaven like the smoke of the Temple incense offering. This section specifically focuses on prayer as a spiritual substitute for the Temple incense service.

Discourse 7

קרבן תענית / Sacrifice of Fasting

פרק א׳

Chapter 1

חלק שני

Part Two

מה יעשה האיש אשר מלכו
חפץ ביקרו יבלה ימיו בטוב
ושנותיו בנעימים ובעת במרום
תמריא וירים לעד קולו וישב
בדד וידום ויאחז פני כסא מידי
חושבו בנשמתו ובגדולת בוראו
איזה דרך יחלק אורו וגם כי
בסלע תחתון ישכון ויתלונן
למרחוק עיני שכלו יביטו ויבין
מפלשי עב ואיך פרש עליו הודו
ולזאת יחרד לבו ויתר ממקומו
על כי רעתו רבה ואין קץ לעונו
ומה יעשה ויחיה יקדש עצמו
במשרתי עליון לפחות יום א׳
בכל מחזור המאור הקטן מדי
חדש בחדשו כי אפי׳ יום אחד
בשנה חשוב שנה כההוא דהוו
קרו ליה בר בי רב דחד יומא
וכ״ש אם יהיה מבני העולם הבא

What should a person do if his King desires his honor?[1] He should spend his days in goodness and his years in pleasantness. And when he soars upward and raises his voice forever, sitting alone in silence, 5R
grasping the face of the throne while contemplating his soul and the greatness of his Creator, which path should he take to distribute His light?[2] Even though he dwells and lodges in the lowest rock,[3] his eyes of intellect gaze afar, perceiving the expanses 10R
of the clouds and how His glory spreads over him. For this reason his heart trembles and shudders from its place, because his wickedness is great and his sin has no end. What should he do to live? He should sanctify himself like the servants of the Most 15R
High for at least one day during each cycle of the lesser luminary[4] [the moon], from month to month. For even one day in a year is considered a year, like that case where they called someone “a one-day scholar.” How much more so if he becomes one of 20R

[1]The King here refers to God, and the phrase suggests divine favor. The passage is addressing how a person should respond when God shows special favor or interest in them.
[2]This suggests that one of the spiritual seeker's responsibilities is to not only receive divine light but also to channel it outward, becoming a vessel for divine influence in the world.
[3]This is a metaphor for the physical body and material existence, contrasted with the soul's ability to perceive spiritual realms despite being confined to physicality.
[4]This refers to the monthly lunar cycle. In Kabbalistic thought, the moon (the ‘lesser luminary’ from Genesis 1:16) represents the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah) that waxes and wanes. Fasting during the moon's waning phase is presented as a way to participate in cosmic restoration.

וילבש מדא ועטופא דמצוה ודקדושה באגרא דתעניתא בכל עת מיעוט הלבנה כי חסד אל ישגיח בכחו ויפרוש עליו אורו וישיב נפשו מני שחת לאור באור החיים. כתר לי אחי זעיר ואחוך בקרבן תענית זה כי אך טוב לישראל הוא: [i]

those destined for the World to Come, and wears the garment and wrapping of commandment and holiness at the expense of fasting during each time of the moon's waning. For God's loving-kindness will watch over him with His power, spread His light upon him, and restore his soul from destruction to walk in the light of life. Wait for me a little, my brother,[1] and I will teach you about this sacrifice of fasting, for it is only good for Israel.

נמצא כתוב בשם האלהי חסידא קדישא הרב רבי יצחק לוריא אשכנזי[ii] כל מה שתמצא בדברי הראשונים תוכחות על עונות סגופים ויסורים קשים שלג וחרולים והפסקות וענויים[iii] לא נזכרו אלא למי שאין עמלו בתורה אבל מי שתורתו אומנותו ויודע דעת ויראת ה׳ זאת היא תקנתו לא יחלש ולא יבטל מלמודו כי התורה היא אש ומים[iv] המוציאה לרויה האדם העוסק בה והיא תבלין נגד יצה״ר[v] כדאמרו במדרש תהלים על פסוק בלבי צפנתי אמרתך מי שהתורה בלבו אין יצה״ר שולט

It is written in the name of the divine, holy, pious Rabbi Isaac Luria Ashkenazi that all the admonitions concerning sins,[2] severe mortifications, suffering, snow, thorns, fasts, and afflictions that you find in the writings of the early authorities were mentioned only for those who do not labor in Torah study. But for one whose Torah study is his occupation[3] and who knows knowledge and fear of the Lord, this is his remedy: he should not weaken nor cease from his studies. For the Torah is fire and water, bringing satisfaction to the person who engages with it, and it is an antidote against the evil inclination, as they said in the Midrash on Psalms regarding the verse, "I have hidden Your word in my heart" [Psalm 119:11]—one who has Torah in his heart, the evil inclination has no dominion over

[1] The Hebrew 'כתר לי אחי זעיר' literally means 'crown me a little, my brother,' but is an idiomatic expression meaning 'wait for me' or 'bear with me.' The author is transitioning to a detailed explanation of fasting practices that follows.

[2] The original text lists specific forms of mortification and suffering that were prescribed by earlier Jewish pietistic literature as penance for sins, including exposure to snow, thorns, and various forms of fasting and self-affliction.

[3] The Hebrew phrase "torato umnuto" is a Talmudic term referring to someone whose primary occupation is Torah study, often used for full-time scholars.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part 1, Introduction — This passage echoes the introduction's focus on spiritual introspection and preparation for death through sacred practices | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse (Siftei Tzedek), Chapter on Visiting the Sick — This passage extends the first discourse's themes about spiritual preparation to monthly fasting practices as another means of achieving spiritual purification | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:2 — The passage's emphasis on contemplating one's mortality and spiritual state echoes Ecclesiastes' wisdom about reflecting on life's end

[ii] This refers to Rabbi Isaac Luria (1534-1572), known as the ARI (the Lion), who revolutionized Kabbalah in Safed. The honorific "ha-Elohi" (the divine) indicates his perceived supernatural spiritual stature.

[iii] This refers to ascetic practices common in medieval Jewish pietistic literature, including rolling in snow, fasting, and self-mortification as penance for sins. The ARI is presented as rejecting these for Torah scholars.

[iv] This is a kabbalistic concept that Torah contains seemingly opposite qualities—both the severity of fire (din/gevurah) and the kindness of water (chesed), making it a perfect balance of divine attributes that can purify the soul.

[v] This refers to the Talmudic statement (Kiddushin 30b): "I created the evil inclination, and I created Torah as its antidote (tavlin)"—literally "spice" or "remedy."

בו ולא נוגע בו וכה״א תורת
אלהיו בלבו לא תמעד אשוריו
והיא תושיה לבחות חומריות
והיא כיין המשמח ודבש הממתיק
וחלב המלבין ושמן המצחצח
לנפש רוח ונשמה[i] ואמרו במדרש
אפי׳ אדם יוצא למיתה התורה
שלמד בה היא משיבה נפשו
באומרו תורת ה׳ תמימה משיבת
נפש ואמרו במדרש תהלים כי
יצה״ר אין לו רשות ליכנס בבית
המדרש וכה״א לפתח חטאת
רובץ וכל מי שהוא עוסק בתורה
אין יצה״ר שולט בו וגרסי׳
בשמות רבה קחו עמכם דברים
ואין דברים אלא ד״ת שנאמר
אלה הדברים ודברים אני מבקש
ואני מוחל לכם כל עונותיכם
א״ל אין אנו יודעין א״ל בואו
והתפללו לפני ואני מקבל
תפלתכם ואמר הקב״ה פיהם
של ישראל הוא חרבם[ii] שנאמר
רוממות אל בגרונם. אך עצת זו
ישפר עליה יום אחד מהשבוע
יתרחק מבני אדם[iii] [iv]

him and does not touch him. And so it says, “The Torah of his God is in his heart; his steps do not falter” [Psalm 37:31]. It [Torah] is substance for the material faculties, and it is like wine that gladdens, honey that sweetens, milk that whitens, and oil that polishes[1] for the soul, spirit, and higher soul. And they said in the Midrash, “Even if a person is going to his death, the Torah he has learned restores his soul,” as it says, “The Torah of the Lord is perfect, restoring the soul” [Psalm 19:8]. And they said in the Midrash on Psalms that the evil inclination has no permission to enter the house of study, and so it says, “Sin crouches at the door” [Genesis 4:7]. And whoever engages in Torah study, the evil inclination has no dominion over him. And we read in Exodus Rabbah: “’Take words with you’ [Hosea 14:3]—and ‘words’ refers only to words of Torah, as it is said, ‘These are the words’ [Deuteronomy 1:1]. [God says:] ‘I seek words, and I will forgive all your sins.’ They said to Him, ‘We do not know [what to say].’ He said to them, ‘Come and pray before Me, and I will accept your prayer.’” And the Holy One, blessed be He, said, “The mouth of Israel is their sword,”[2] as it is said, “The high praises of God are in their throats” [Psalm 149:6]. But this advice he should improve upon: one day of the week he should distance himself

[1] This poetic formulation presents Torah as affecting all aspects of human existence through four sensory metaphors corresponding to different aspects of spiritual experience.

[2] This metaphor draws on the continuation of Psalm 149:6, which mentions “a two-edged sword in their hands.” The midrash reinterprets this to mean that Israel’s power comes through their mouths—through prayer and Torah study—rather than physical weapons.

[i] This references the kabbalistic concept of the three main levels of the soul: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). The text suggests Torah study positively affects all three levels.

[ii] This references the idea that Israel’s power lies in prayer and Torah study rather than physical weapons. It connects to Psalm 149:6, “The high praises of God in their throats and a two-edged sword in their hands.”

[iii] This introduces the concept of hitbodedut (spiritual seclusion or meditation), a practice emphasized in various Jewish mystical traditions, particularly in Hasidism.

[iv] Cf. Exodus Rabbah 38:4 — The author cites this midrash to support the idea that Torah study is more powerful than physical mortifications as a spiritual remedy, emphasizing that words of Torah and prayer are what God truly desires from us. | Cf. Psalm 19:8 (19:7 in Christian Bibles) — This scriptural reference is used to emphasize the author’s main point that Torah study has restorative power even for someone facing death, positioning Torah study as superior to physical mortifications. | Cf. Psalms 149:6 — The author uses this reference to highlight the power of the mouth through prayer and Torah study, metaphorically describing it as Israel’s ‘sword’—their spiritual weapon against sin and suffering. | Cf. Genesis 4:7 — This verse is used to illustrate that the evil inclination (yetzer hara) waits outside the house of study but cannot enter it, emphasizing Torah study as a protected space free from spiritual corruption. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author is drawing on kabbalistic imagery of Torah having paradoxical qualities that make it uniquely suited to balance human nature and combat the evil inclination. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok, Fourth Discourse, Part One — This passage creates a parallel between Torah study and the

from people[1]

ויתבודד בינו לבין קונו ותתקשר מחשבתו בו כאילו כבר עמד לפניו ביום הדין וידבר לאל יתברך רכות כאשר ידבר העבד אל רבו והבן מול אביו וכמה היה מזרז על זה החכם מורי כמהר״ר ישראל סרוק זצ״ל בשם רבותיו.[i] מצינו כמה חסידים שהיו בוררים להם ימים מיוחדים ולא היו רוצים לראות שום אדם אלא מתפללים וקוראים כל היום לעצמם ואם מחמת איזה אונס הוצרך להם לראות פני אדם לא היו מתעכבים עמו זמן רב. וכתב בעל ספר החרדים ובכמה חברים הראשונים נמצא שבהתבודדות והפרישות והדבקות היו נוהגים בו חסידים יע״ש ולמד מהרר״י מקובל הנ״ל שזה מועיל לנפש שבעתים מהלימוד[ii] ולפי כח ויכולת האדם יפרוש ויתבודד יום אחד בשבוע או בכל ט״ו יום או יום א׳ לחדש ולא יפחות מזה[iii] וכ״כ הרמב״ן על מה שנאמר ביעקב אבינו קום עלה בית אל ושב שם מאי ושב כמו בשובה ונחת

And he should seclude himself with his Creator, and his thoughts should be bound to Him as if he already stood before Him on the Day of Judgment,[2] and he should speak gently to God, blessed be He, as a servant speaks to his master and a son before his father. And how much did my teacher, the sage Rabbi Israel Sarug of blessed memory, urge this practice in the name of his teachers. We find that many pious ones would select specific days when they did not wish to see any person, but would pray and read by themselves all day, and if due to some necessity they needed to see someone, they would not tarry with them for long. And the author of Sefer HaCharedim wrote that among many of the early companions, it is found that the pious ones practiced seclusion, separation, and devotion, see there. And Rabbi Israel the Kabbalist mentioned above taught that this benefits the soul sevenfold more than study.[3] According to one's strength and ability, one should separate and seclude oneself one day a week, or every fifteen days, or one day a month, but not less than this. And so wrote Nachmanides regarding what was said of our father Jacob, "Rise, go up to Beth El and dwell there"[4]—what does "dwell" mean? Like "in returning and rest," meaning that he should prepare his mind in calmness and settled awareness with the Blessed One. And we find in the Zohar, Parashat Be-

[1]This introduces the practice of spiritual solitude (hitbodedut), suggesting a balanced approach that combines Torah study with periodic withdrawal for contemplation and spiritual refinement.

[2]This imagery connects the practice of spiritual seclusion with preparation for divine judgment, suggesting that hitbodedut serves as a rehearsal for the ultimate encounter with God after death.

[3]The numerical specification 'sevenfold' likely carries kabbalistic significance, as the number seven represents completeness or perfection in Jewish tradition. This suggests that hitbodedut offers a more complete spiritual benefit than conventional study.

[4]The passage interprets Jacob's ascent to Beth El (literally 'House of God') as a spiritual practice rather than merely a geographical movement, connecting physical pilgrimage with internal spiritual journey.

incense offering discussed earlier in the book—both serve as spiritual protections against harmful forces and provide healing to the soul.

[i]The author identifies Rabbi Israel Sarug as his teacher and a transmitter of the mystical practice of hitbodedut (spiritual seclusion). This indicates a direct chain of kabbalistic tradition from Sarug to the author. Rabbi Israel Sarug was a prominent kabbalist who spread Lurianic Kabbalah throughout Italy in the late 16th century.

[ii]This is a striking claim that spiritual seclusion (hitbodedut) benefits the soul seven times more than Torah study. This represents a distinctly mystical prioritization that differs from mainstream rabbinic tradition, which typically elevates Torah study above all other religious practices.

[iii]The text provides a practical graduated system for the practice of spiritual seclusion based on individual capacity, with minimum requirements. This demonstrates the practical rather than purely theoretical orientation of Ma'avar Yabok's mystical guidance.

היינו שיכין דעתו בשובה ובישוב
הדעת עמו יתברך. ומצינו בזהר
פ׳ בשלח דף מ״ד ע״ב כי אלישע
100 לא היה נקרא איש האלהים
אלא בהיותו מתבודד לעצמו
דאמר מאי שנא הכא דאמר איש
האלהים וכד הוה במתא אלישע
אלא הכא ודאי איש האלהים
105 דהכא היא דוכתיה ולא במתא
ולא בשעתא דהוו בני נשא קמיה
עוד אמר שם דאמר אלישע בגין
דמתפרשנא בלחוד באתר דא
אצטריכנא לאסתכלא ברגיזו
110 דעלמא. וזהו ששנינו חסידים
הראשונים היו שוהים שעה אחת
וכו׳. שהיו מפנים דעתם מענייני
העולם ומקשרים דעתם לאדון
הכל במורא ובאהבה ומדמים
115 אור השכינה שעל ראשיהם כאילו
מתפשט סביבם והם בתוך האור
יושבים[i] ואז היו רועדים בטבע
ושמחים על אותה רעדה[ii] כדבר
שנאמר עבדו את ה׳ ביראה
120 וגילו ברעדה. ויפה לאדם
להרגיל עצמו להתבודד בכל
יום בבית הכנסת לעצמו אחר
תפלת שחרית מוכתר בתפילין
ובציצית[iii] ויקבע לו שם עת
125 קבוע להתבודדות וללמוד כל
אחד כפי יכלתו ויהיו לטוטפות

shalach, page 44b, that Elisha was not called "man of God" except when he was secluding himself, as it says, "What is different here that it says 'man of God,' while when Elisha was in the city [it doesn't]? Rather, certainly here he is 'man of God,' for this is his place, not in the city, and not when people are before him." It further says there that Elisha said, "Because I separate myself alone in this place, I need to contemplate the agitation of the world."[1] And this is what we learned: "The early pious ones would wait one hour, etc."—for they would clear their minds of worldly matters and bind their thoughts to the Master of All in awe and love, and they would imagine the light of the Divine Presence above their heads as if it spread around them, and they sat within the light, and then they would tremble naturally and rejoice in that trembling,[2] as it is said, "Serve the Lord with fear, and rejoice with trembling." And it is good for a person to accustom himself to seclude himself every day in the synagogue alone after the morning prayer, crowned with tefillin and tzitzit,[3] and to establish for himself there a fixed time for seclusion and study, each according to his ability, and let the words of the Psalmist be as frontlets between his eyes: "But I am like a green olive tree in the house of God, etc.""

100R 105R 110R 115R 120R

[1] This suggests that part of the purpose of seclusion is not merely to escape worldly concerns but to gain perspective on them from a position of spiritual detachment, allowing for clearer contemplation of human affairs.

[2] This describes a physical response to mystical practice that combines seemingly contradictory states: trembling (typically associated with fear) and joy. This paradoxical experience reflects the complexity of mystical encounters with the divine as both awesome and delightful.

[3] The imagery of being 'crowned' with ritual objects elevates these physical items to symbols of spiritual royalty, suggesting that through proper observance, the practitioner takes on a quasi-royal spiritual status during hitbodedut practice.

[i] This describes a specific visualization technique in which the practitioner imagines being surrounded by divine light. This practice relates to similar techniques in both Lurianic Kabbalah and earlier Heikhalot mysticism where visualization of divine light plays a central role in achieving mystical states.

[ii] The text describes physical trembling as a natural physiological response to deep meditation, accompanied by spiritual joy. This description of bodily reactions to mystical practice is significant for understanding the embodied nature of Jewish mysticism, which doesn't separate physical and spiritual experience.

[iii] The recommendation to practice hitbodedut while wearing tefillin and tzitzit illustrates how this mystical practice is integrated with traditional Jewish ritual observance rather than standing apart from it.

בין עיניו דברי המשורר ואני
כזית רענן בבית אלהים וגו׳. [i]

הנה זאת חקרנוה כן היא כי
מה טוב ומה נעים לכל משכיל
דורש את ה׳ שבכל ערב ראש
חדש לפחות יקרא יום צום
ורצון לה׳ [ii] ומצינו במדרש
תהלים דבתפלת יום א׳ נקרא
האדם צדיק הרבה בדף ט״ל
ע״ב ויכוין כי גופו יהיה מזבח
כפרה במיעוט חלבו ודמו על
מיעוט הירח העליונה [iii] ובזה
יהיה שכרו על ה׳ אלהיו וזה
יכוין בכוונה שהביא בזהר פ׳
וארא דף כ״ז ע״א בפסוק ואהבת
את ה׳ אלהיך ובפרט בפסוק
שמע ישראל ובנפילת אפים
ויאמר בקשת המתחלת בכתר אל
שבסדר ראש חדש במעירי שחר
שלנו מכוונת על חדוש הלבנה
העליונה ואם יפסוק תעניתו

Behold, we have investigated this and confirmed it: How good and pleasant it is for every wise person who seeks the Lord to designate at least every eve of the new month as a day of fasting and divine favor. We find in the Midrash on Psalms that through prayer on a single day, a person can be called exceedingly righteous, as stated on page 39b. One should intend that one's body serve as an altar of atonement,[1] diminishing one's fat and blood in correspondence with the waning of the supernal moon,[2] and thereby one's reward will come from the Lord. This intention should follow the kavvanah (mystical intention) brought in the Zohar, Parashat Va'era, page 27a, regarding the verse "And you shall love the Lord your God," particularly when reciting the Shema Yisrael and during Nefilat Apayim (prostration prayer). One should recite the supplication beginning with "Crown of God" from our "Illuminators of Dawn" New Moon service,

[1] This metaphor of the body as an altar appears throughout Jewish mystical literature. Through fasting, the diminishment of bodily fat and blood is likened to a sacrificial offering, creating a spiritual parallel to Temple worship.

[2] The timing of this practice at the end of the month (when the moon wanes) is significant. Kabbalistic thought views the monthly cycle of the moon as reflecting cosmic processes involving the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). Human ritual action at this time is believed to contribute to cosmic restoration.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach, page 44b — The author uses this Zohar reference to demonstrate that even biblical prophets like Elisha achieved their highest spiritual status not in cities or among people, but in seclusion. This supports the text's central argument that spiritual contemplation in isolation is superior to public religious activity. | Cf. Psalms 2:11 — This biblical verse is used to legitimize the mystical practice of hitbodedut (seclusion) by showing that the trembling that occurs during deep meditation is not a negative response but part of proper divine service as described in scripture. | Cf. Psalms 52:10 — This psalm verse is offered as a meditation focus, with the image of a flourishing olive tree in God's house representing the spiritual vitality that comes from regular hitbodedut practice. | Cf. Sefer HaCharedim — By citing Sefer HaCharedim (a 16th century ethical work), the author is connecting his recommended practices to an established tradition, showing that hitbodedut has precedent in earlier rabbinic literature and is not an innovation. | Cf. Genesis 35:1 — By citing Nachmanides' interpretation of this verse, the author establishes biblical precedent for the practice of spiritual seclusion, suggesting that God's command to Jacob was actually an instruction to engage in contemplative spiritual practice. | Cf. Isaiah 30:15 — The author connects the command to Jacob with Isaiah's teaching about salvation coming through quietness and trust, suggesting that spiritual seclusion (hitbodedut) is aligned with prophetic teachings about how to connect with the divine.

[ii] The author is recommending at minimum a monthly fast on the eve of each new month (Erev Rosh Chodesh), which became known as Yom Kippur Katan (Minor Day of Atonement) in Jewish practice.

[iii] This establishes a mystical correspondence between the human body during fasting and the waning moon. In Kabbalah, the moon symbolizes the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) or Malkhut (the lowest sefirah), and its monthly diminishment represents a cosmic state requiring rectification through human ritual action.

ויקבל הוא עליו מבעוד יום
באופן שיהיה כ״ו שעות בתענית
זה יפה מאד ולא יאכל בקבלת
תענית זה בשר ולא ישתה יין
אלא פת וקטנית כסעודת עבור
החדש או פת הצנומא בקדירה
או פת ופירות ואח״כ יטבול
פעם אחת פתו באפר ויפסיק
ויפריש בכל שעה מכ״ו שעות
התענית פרוטה מכיסו ליתנה
לעני הגון בלילה קודם שיאכל
באופן שיהיו לפחות כ״ו פרוטות
ובזה ירחיב לו קב״ה כנפ״י
החסד. ובהפרשת כל פרוטה
יאמר אני בצדק אחזה פניך[i] צדק
צדק תרדוף למען תחיה וגו׳
או ה׳ זכרנו ברך. או מזמור
שמעה ה׳ צדק או בבא אליו. או
שיר המעלות ממעמקים קראתיך
וכדומה. ובעת שרוצה לשכב
על מטתו יפריש כל הפרוטות
משעות שיעברו עליו בשינתו
ויכוין לביסום מדת הדין וליחדה
עם מדת החסד אשא במיא ומיא
באשא[ii] וישים לבו במחשבה
ורעותא ליחוד תרין דודין
עילאין בסוד רוחא וליחוד
קוב״ה ושכינתיה בקלא ודבורא
דיליה ולעורר עליו כ״ו החסדים
הגדולים שבהלל הגדול[iii] בכח
שם העצם בן ד׳ אותיות ברוך
הוא בנקודתו הידוע ויחשוב כי
בהאיר האותיות ונקודות שם

which is directed toward the renewal of the supernal moon. 145R

If one concludes one's fast having accepted it while still daytime, so that the fast lasts twenty-six hours,[1] this is very beneficial. During the meal before the fast, one should not eat meat nor drink wine, but rather consume bread and legumes like a 150R meal marking the passing of the month, or bread soaked in a pot, or bread and fruits. Afterward, one should dip one's bread once in ashes[2] and then break one's fast. For each of the twenty-six hours of the fast, one should set aside a perutah (small 155R coin) from one's pocket to give to a worthy poor person on the night before eating, so that there are at least twenty-six perutot. Through this, the Holy One, blessed be He, will extend to you the wings of kindness. 160R

When setting aside each perutah, one should say: "Through righteousness I shall behold Your face" or "Pursue justice, that you may live" or "O Lord, remember us and bless us" or Psalm 17 ("Hear, O Lord, righteousness") or Psalm 7 ("When he came 165R to him") or Psalm 130 ("From the depths I called You") or similar verses. When preparing to lie down on one's bed, set aside all the perutot for the hours that will pass during sleep, and intend to sweeten the attribute of judgment and unite it with the attribute 170R of loving-kindness[3]—fire in water and water in fire. Focus one's heart in thought and will on unifying the two supernal beloveds in the mystery of spirit, and on unifying the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence through one's voice and speech, and to 175R awaken the twenty-six great kindnesses mentioned in

[1] The specification of 26 hours is significant because 26 is the numerical value of the divine name YHVH (10+5+6+5). This creates a correspondence between the duration of the fast and God's essential name.

[2] This symbolic action of dipping bread in ashes before ending the fast represents humility and mortality, similar to the custom of placing ashes on the forehead on fast days.

[3] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgments' (המתקת הדינים), where harsh divine judgment (din) is tempered with mercy (rachamim) through proper ritual actions, creating cosmic harmony.

[i] The verse 'Through righteousness I shall behold Your face' (Psalm 17:15) creates a connection between the act of charity (tzedakah, from the same root as tzedek, righteousness) and divine vision. The other suggested verses also emphasize righteousness and divine assistance.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase meaning 'fire in water and water in fire' refers to the kabbalistic concept of harmonizing opposing forces (fire representing judgment/Gevurah and water representing kindness/Chesed) to create spiritual balance.

[iii] The 'Great Hallel' (Psalm 136) contains 26 verses, each ending with 'for His kindness endures forever.' The number 26 corresponds to the numerical value of the divine name YHVH (10+5+6+5), connecting these acts of kindness directly to God's essential nature.

הקדוש הזה יאורו ויתוקנו כל
שאר ההויות המסתעפים ממנו
כי רוח פחד לכל ועיין במדרש
קהלת דף ע״ג ע״ב קדושת שם
185 המפורש קצת מכחו הנאדרי
ובלילה בהתבודדותו יקרא
משירי דוד בפיו בקול ובניגונים
ויעסוק במשנה ואם שגור בפיו
סדר קדשים היה טוב לקרותו
190 כלו בכל היום ההוא ולפחות
יקרא זבחים ומנחות ותמיד
ומדות כדאמרי׳ במדרש תלמידי
חכמים העוסקים בהלכות
עבודה מעלה אני עליהם כאלו
195 נבנה בית המקדש בימיהם שבין
כלם הם ט״ל פרקים כמספר
יה״ו במילוי האותיות והוא
סוד מוריד הטל ויוסיף עוד
לקרואי׳ פרקים במסכת יומא
200 שהם מ״ט פרקים[i] לפתוח עליו
מ״ט שערי טהרה ולהבריח
מעליו המ״ט מדרגות הטומאה
בסגולת המשניות שהם בסוד עץ
הדעת טוב ורע ורשב״י בפרשה
205 שמות דף ט״ו ע״ב הביא כמה
רמזים למספר המ״ט:[ii]

the Great Hallel through the power of the four-letter essential Name, blessed is He, with its known vowelization. Consider that when the letters and vowel points of this holy Name illuminate, all other divine 180R
Names that branch from it will be illuminated and rectified, for the spirit of awe is upon all, as explained in Midrash Kohelet, page 73b, regarding the sanctity of the explicit Name and some of its glorious power.

During the night in solitude, recite David's songs 185R
aloud with melodies, and engage in studying Mishnah. If you are fluent in the Order of Kodashim (Holy Things), it would be good to recite it all on that day. At minimum, read Zevachim, Menachot, Tamid, and Middot, as they stated in the Midrash: 190R
"I consider Torah scholars who engage in the laws of the Temple service as if the Temple were rebuilt in their days."[1] Together, these comprise thirty-nine chapters, corresponding to the numerical value of YH"V when spelled with full letters, which is the 195R
mystery of "Who brings down the dew." One should add more chapters from the tractate Yoma, which has forty-nine chapters, to open the forty-nine gates of purity and drive away the forty-nine levels of impurity through the power of the Mishnayot, which re- 200R
late to the mystery of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, in Parashat Shemot, page 15b, brought several allusions to the number forty-nine.

[1] This reflects the rabbinic principle that studying the laws of Temple service can spiritually substitute for the actual Temple rituals that can no longer be performed after the Temple's destruction. In kabbalistic thought, such study creates the same cosmic effects as the original rituals.

[i] The number 49 appears frequently in Jewish mysticism, representing completeness (7×7) and the fullness of divine emanation. The 49 gates of purity mentioned later correspond to the 49 days of the Omer counting between Passover and Shavuot, seen as a period of spiritual purification.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Va'era, page 27a — The author is referring readers to the Zohar's explanation of how one's intention during prayer can affect cosmic realities, particularly how proper devotion during the Shema can influence the waning moon, which has kabbalistic associations with the divine feminine (Malkhut). | Cf. Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) — This appears to be either the author's own prayer collection or one used by his community in Modena. The reference indicates that the author is integrating his existing liturgical work with the spiritual practices described in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Midrash on Psalms, page 39b — The author uses this midrashic source to establish the spiritual efficacy of devoting even a single day to prayer and fasting, suggesting that the eve of the new moon is especially potent for such spiritual work. | Cf. Midrash Kohelet, page 73b — The author references this midrash to substantiate his claims about the cosmic power of divine names, particularly how visualizing the Tetragrammaton with its proper vowelization can illuminate all other divine names that derive from it. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Shemot, page 15b — This reference connects the practice of studying 49 chapters of Mishnah to the 49 gates of purity and the mystical structure of the cosmos as explained in the Zohar. It reinforces the kabbalistic worldview that specific numbers of ritual actions correspond to cosmic structures.

פרק ב׳

Chapter 2

וראוי לבעל תורה להרגיל
עצמו לקרוא לפחות שתא סדרי
משנה[i] פעם אחת בשנה בהבנת
פשטי דבריהם כי נעמו ואשרי
ת״ח שמשומר למודו בידו
כדאמרי׳ במדרש משלי דף ס״ט
ע״א שהקב״ה אומר לת״ח הבא
לפניו אמור לפני מה שקרית
ומה ששנית מכאן אמרו כל מה
שקרא ושנה האדם יהיה תפוס
בידו שלא תשיגהו בלימה ליום
הדין וע״ש מכל פרטי השאלות
ששואלין לת״ח ובדף ס״ח ע״א
ספר בכבוד שנעשה ע״י אליהו
לר״ע אחר מיתתו[ii] ואיך הושכב
על מטתו בכבוד והדר כי ברכה
לראש משביר[iii] ואם המתענה
הזה אינו בעל משנה ירבה
בשירי דוד ובעניות אחרונות
שבאיוב[iv] ויקראם בקול ובנחת
כי טוב מעט בכוונה מהרבות
בלא כוונה. בלילה קודם שכבו
ישב על גבי קרקע בחליצת
מנעל וסנדל ויתאבל על חרבן
הבית[v] ויספוד ויאנח בנוסח אהה

It is proper for a Torah scholar to accustom himself to read through the six orders of the Mishnah at least once a year, understanding their plain meanings, for they are pleasant. And fortunate is the Torah scholar whose learning is preserved in his hand,[1] as stated in Midrash Mishlei, page 69a, that the Holy One, blessed be He, says to the Torah scholar who comes before Him: "Tell Me what you have read and what you have studied." From here they said that whatever a person has read and studied will remain firmly in his grasp, so that he will not be overcome with shame on the Day of Judgment.[2] See there for all the detailed questions that are asked of Torah scholars. And on page 68a, it describes the honor that was shown by Elijah to Rabbi Akiva after his death, and how he was laid upon his bed with honor and glory, for "blessing is upon the head of the provider."

If this faster is not versed in Mishnah, he should increase his recitation of David's songs [Psalms] and the final lamentations of Job, and read them aloud and calmly, for a little with intention is better than much without intention.[3] At night before lying down, he should sit on the ground with shoes and sandals removed, and mourn for the destruction of the Temple,[4] and lament and sigh with the

[1] This metaphorical expression means that the scholar has retained his learning in his memory and can readily access it.

[2] This reflects the Jewish belief that in the afterlife, people will be asked to demonstrate their Torah knowledge. Those who have forgotten what they learned will feel shame.

[3] This reflects a significant principle in Jewish religious thought that the quality of one's devotion (kavvanah/intention) often matters more than quantity. This concept appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok, particularly regarding prayer and rituals for the sick and dying.

[4] The destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem (first in 586 BCE by the Babylonians, then in 70 CE by the Romans) remains a central focus of Jewish mourning practices. By connecting personal fasting with national tragedy, the text integrates individual spiritual practice with collective historical consciousness.

[i] The six orders of the Mishnah are Zeraim (Seeds), Moed (Festival), Nashim (Women), Nezikin (Damages), Kodashim (Holy Things), and Taharot (Purities). Together they form the foundation of rabbinic Judaism's oral law.

[ii] This refers to a tradition that the prophet Elijah (who never died according to biblical accounts) honored Rabbi Akiva (R"A) after his martyrdom at the hands of the Romans. Such stories emphasize the enduring spiritual significance of great scholars even after death.

[iii] This is a reference to Proverbs 11:26, "Blessing will be upon the head of the provider," suggesting that those who share knowledge (like Rabbi Akiva) receive blessings.

[iv] The final chapters of the Book of Job (particularly chapters 38-42) contain God's response to Job from the whirlwind, Job's submission to divine wisdom, and his ultimate restoration. These passages are considered especially profound meditations on human suffering and divine justice.

[v] Mourning for the destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem was a regular practice among pious Jews. This act connects personal fasting and repentance with national tragedy and collective redemption.

נפשי על עוונותי ויאמר הוידוי
שסדרנו ביום ראשון של השבוע
במעירי שחר שלנו[i] וגם שם
לפניו הסדר הראוי ליאמר בכל
30 לילה אך בליל זה יוכל להוסיף
ברצונו מסדרים הכתובים שם
ואם אינו יוכל לקום הרבה קודם
אור היום[ii]

formula "Alas, my soul, for my sins," and recite the confession that we arranged for the first day of the week in our "Me'irei Shachar"[1] [Illuminators of Dawn], and also place before him the order that is proper to recite every night. But on this night he may add as he wishes from the orders written there. And if he cannot rise long before daylight... 30R

לפחות יאריך בבקשות עד
35 אחר חצות ברם היה יותר טוב
להקדים לשכב בנשף ראשון
ולקיים ביום הקדוש הזה חצות
לילה אקום[iii] וקודם קומו
מהארץ יתן בעפר פיו[iv] בבכי
40 ודמעה ויאריך בפסוקי שמירה
ברצונו וטוב שישכב עם בתי
ידים בידיו ואזור במתניו
ובהקיצו משנתו בעודו על
משכבו ירחש איזה פסוקי דרחמי
45 כאשר ישים ה׳ בפיו ויכוין
לתקון השעות שעברו ושיעברו
עליו בשינתו ועכ״פ יתחזק
לקשר מדת לילה ביום ויעסוק
במשניות קדשים ובספר הזהר
50 אם חלק לו ה׳ בו חלק ויקרא
פרק דספרא דצניעותא[v] שהם

He should at least prolong his supplications until after midnight. However, it would be better to go to sleep early in the evening and fulfill on this holy day [the verse] "At midnight I will rise" [Psalms 119:62]. Before rising from the ground, he should place his mouth in the dust with weeping and tears, and extend his recitation of protective verses according to his desire. It is good to lie down with hand coverings on his hands and a belt around his loins. Upon awakening, while still on his bed, he should murmur some verses of mercy as God places in his mouth, and he should focus his intention on rectifying the hours that have passed and will pass during his sleep. In any case, he should strive to connect the attribute of night with day,[A] and he should study Mishnah tractates of the Order of Kodashim [Holy Things] and the Book of Zohar if God has granted him a portion in it.[2] He should read a chapter of Safra 35R 40R 45R 50R

[A] Or: "he should strengthen himself to bind the quality of night with day" — This alternate translation maintains the more literal sense of 'strengthen himself' (יתחזק) and 'bind' (לקשר), which might better preserve the active spiritual effort implied in the original. However, the original translation effectively communicates the kabbalistic concept involved.

[1] This appears to be the author's own prayer collection, organized by days of the week. The name means "Illuminators of Dawn," suggesting prayers meant to be recited in the early morning hours.
[2] This phrase reflects the common rabbinic attitude that understanding of mystical texts like the

[i] "Me'irei Shachar" (Illuminators of Dawn) was the author's own prayer collection, organized by days of the week with specific prayers, confessions, and meditations for different occasions.
[ii] Cf. Midrash Mishlei — This reference supports the importance of retaining Torah study in one's memory, as the Holy One will ask scholars to recite what they have learned when they come before Him after death. | Cf. Midrash Mishlei — This reference describes the honor shown to Rabbi Akiva after his death by Elijah, reinforcing the author's point about the eternal value of Torah study and the respect accorded to scholars even after death. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — This is the author's own prayer collection, which he references to guide the reader to specific confessional prayers to be recited during the fasting practice he is describing.
[iii] This is a reference to Psalms 119:62, "At midnight I will rise to give thanks to You for Your righteous judgments." Rising at midnight for prayer and study is considered especially meritorious in Jewish mystical tradition.
[iv] This practice of placing one's mouth in the dust refers to the biblical verse in Lamentations 3:29, "Let him put his mouth in the dust; perhaps there is hope." It symbolizes complete humility and submission before God during intense supplication.
[v] Safra D'Tzniuta (Book of Concealment) is one of the most esoteric and cryptic sections of the Zohar, containing profound mystical teachings. It appears in the Zohar's commentary on the Torah portion of Terumah.

בפרשת תרומה ואח״כ ילך
למשמרתו עם אחוזת מריעיו
להתפלל על חרבן הבית[i] כאשר
הצגנו לפני בני גילנו על פי
הכוונה שהיא בהקדמת אשמורת
הבקר שלנו המכוונת מאד כפי
עניות דעתנו לתקון יום כזה
כאשר עיני המעיין בצדק ישפוט
ויבין ויוסיף מדעתו אך לא
יהיה לו שיח וסיג עם שום אחד
מהם רק להצטרף עמהם לענות
דברים שבקדושה וינעים בפיו
הזמירות בבית הכנסת ויתפלל
במורא ויראה רבה ויכוין
בתפלתו כפי הבנתו וישתדל
להשלים ק׳ ברכות[ii] בעניית
אמו אחרי ברכות השחר מבניו
ותלמידיו ויכוין בחזרת שליח
צבור התפלה יותר משאר ימים
ואחר התפלה יתעכב בבית
הכנסת מעוטר בציצית ותפלין
ושם יעסוק בתחינות ובקשות
ומזמורים כפי כוונתו כי תפלת
ישרים רצונו ואמרו במדרש
תהלים מזמור ק״מ אמר קודשא
בריך הוא לדוד רנן לפני
ואני אפלטך דכתיב רני פלט
תסובבני סלה ואת״ל יקרא
המשניות במסכתות שאמרנו
וישוב ויקרא בספר הזהר ואם

D'Tzniuta [Book of Concealment] which is found in the Torah portion of Terumah. Afterward, he should go to his watch with his companions to pray for the destruction of the Temple, as we have presented before our contemporaries according to the intention 55R
that is in the introduction to our Morning Watch, which is very much directed, according to our limited understanding,[1] toward the rectification appropriate for such a day. The observer will judge fairly, understand, and add from his own knowledge. But 60R
he should not engage in casual conversation or idle chatter[A] with any of them, only joining with them to respond to sacred matters.[2] He should pleasantly chant the hymns in the synagogue and pray with awe and great reverence, directing his inten- 65R
tion in prayer according to his understanding. He should strive to complete the hundred blessings[3] by answering "Amen" after the morning blessings from his sons and disciples. He should concentrate during the prayer leader's repetition of the Amidah more 70R
than on other days. After prayer, he should remain in the synagogue, adorned with tzitzit and tefillin, and there engage in supplications, petitions, and psalms according to his intention, for "the prayer of the upright is His desire" [Proverbs 15:8]. And they said 75R
in Midrash Tehillim, Psalm 140, "The Holy One, blessed be He, said to David: 'Sing before Me and I will deliver you,' as it is written, 'Songs of deliverance surround me, Selah'" [Psalms 32:7]. And if you wish to say, he should read the Mishnah tractates we 80R

[A] Or: "discourse and fence" — The literal translation of 'שיח וסיג' would be 'discourse and fence,' but in this context it appears to be an idiomatic expression for unnecessary or idle conversation. The original translation captures the intended meaning better, though the literal translation might preserve the wordplay in the original Hebrew.

Zohar requires divine assistance and is not equally accessible to all, even with study.

[1] This expression of humility is characteristic of kabbalistic authors who, despite their erudition, emphasize their inadequacy before divine mysteries. It also serves as a rhetorical device to protect against criticism.

[2] This refers to participating in communal prayer elements that require a quorum (minyan), such as Kaddish, Kedushah, and Barchu, while avoiding mundane conversation that would detract from the spiritual focus of the fast day.

[3] This refers to the rabbinic obligation to recite one hundred blessings daily. On fast days when meal blessings are omitted, one needs to be especially conscious to find other ways to reach this number, such as answering 'Amen' to others' blessings.

[i] Praying for the destruction of the Temple refers to lamenting its destruction and praying for its rebuilding, a practice especially appropriate during fast days.

[ii] The obligation to recite one hundred blessings daily is based on a rabbinic interpretation of Deuteronomy 10:12, "What (מה) does the Lord your God require of you..." where the word מה is read as מאה (one hundred).

יתעכב שם בבית הכנסת או בבית מדרשו עד אחר חצות זה יהיה לו תקון גדול וביום יקרא פרשת עשרת הדברות ופרשת הירא שבעקב[i] ואם יאמר סדר המעמדות[ii] נ״ל שיפה עשה ואם יקרא בפיו קצור המצות להרמב״ם או העשי״ן והלאוי״ן שבסמ״ג[iii] או ההזהרות גם זה יהיה תקון לתעניתו.[iv]

mentioned and return to read the Book of Zohar. If he remains there in the synagogue or in his study hall until after midday,[1] this will be a great rectification for him. During the day, he should read the passage of the Ten Commandments and the passage about fear [of God] in [the Torah portion of] Ekev. If he recites the order of Ma'amadot [daily Temple service readings], it seems to me that he has done well. And if he reads aloud the Abbreviated Commandments of Maimonides, or the positive and negative commandments in the Semag [Sefer Mitzvot Gadol], or the admonitions, this too will be a rectification for his fast.[2]

ואם יהיה מלמד תנוקות לא יבטל תלמוד תורה שלהם אך ימעט ממה שכתוב בסדר הזה כי מאן דמתני אין למעלה ממנו[v] ברם יזהר למעט בדברי חול ככל האפשר לו ואל יוציא קללה מפיו ביום ההוא אפילו לא יכוין אלא לזרוק בהם

If he is a teacher of children, he should not neglect their Torah study, but rather reduce some of what is written in this regimen, for one who teaches has no superior. However, he should be careful to minimize secular talk as much as possible and not let a curse escape his lips on that day, even if he only intends to express frustration. Most of his speech should be in the holy tongue [Hebrew]. In summary, this person

[1] The author emphasizes extended prayer and study during fast days, with midday representing a significant threshold. In Jewish tradition, divine mercy is considered more accessible during the morning hours, while judgment intensifies in the afternoon.

[2] The concept of 'rectification' (tikkun) is central to Kabbalah, suggesting that religious practices repair cosmic damage caused by sin. This passage presents multiple ways to achieve such rectification, acknowledging different capacities and preferences among practitioners.

[i] The "passage about fear" refers to Deuteronomy 10:12-22 in the Torah portion of Ekev, which begins with "And now, Israel, what does the Lord your God require of you but to fear the Lord your God..."

[ii] Ma'amadot are selections of Torah readings, prayers, and psalms corresponding to the daily Temple service, recited by those who cannot study Torah full-time as a substitute for the sacrificial offerings.

[iii] The Semag (Sefer Mitzvot Gadol) by Rabbi Moses of Coucy is a 13th-century legal code that organizes the commandments into positive (עשין) and negative (לאוין) precepts.

[iv] Cf. Psalms 119:62 — The author references this verse to promote midnight prayer as a powerful spiritual practice, echoing King David's devotion to rising at midnight for prayer, which Ma'avar Yabok consistently presents as an optimal time for spiritual work. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim, Psalm 140 — This midrashic passage is cited to emphasize the spiritual power of singing praises to God, showing how devotional singing becomes a means of spiritual protection and salvation, which fits with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on prayer as a protective spiritual practice. | Cf. Safra D'Tzniuta in Parshat Terumah — The author recommends reading this esoteric kabbalistic text from the Zohar as part of the spiritual preparation during the fast day. This cryptic and profound text would create a powerful mystical focus, consistent with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on kabbalistic meditation. | Cf. Proverbs 15:8 — This biblical verse is cited to establish the theological foundation for extended prayer, emphasizing that sincere prayer from the righteous is desired by God, supporting the extensive prayer practices recommended throughout Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) — The author references his own prayer society or collection called 'Illuminators of Dawn,' which he has mentioned elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok. This self-reference shows how the current work builds upon his previous liturgical compositions and practices.

[v] This is a Talmudic principle meaning 'one who teaches [Torah to children] has no superior,' emphasizing the supreme religious value of education.

מרה[i] ורוב דבורו יהיה בלשון הקודש[ii] כלל הדברים יראה האיש המתבודד הלז באילו כל היום הזה הוא עומד בג״ע לפני השכינה. ויהא נר דולק בבית הכנסת לשמו להזכיר לטוב נשמתו לפני השם וכבר אמרו בגמרין ובמדרש שיר השירים מפי רבותינו בשבחם יושבי עיר אושא שכר שהושלם לעובד אדום[iii] על שהדליק נר לפני הארון וכבר דברנו בסוד הנר של בית הכנסת במאמר ראשון ומי שאינו בעל משנה יאריך בסדר התחנונים שבמחזורים ויחרוז מתורה לנביאים ומנביאים לכתובים.[iv] עוד נאות למשכיל לקרוא מגילת שיר השירים בכוונה ביום זה כדאמרו שם לא ניתן שיר השירים לישראל אלא לשבחן של ישראל ולבן אין דורשין אותו לעולם לגנאי שלהם כך אמר רבי יהודה לרבי מאיר כמה פעמים. וכלל זה יהיה ביד האדם בכל עת וזמן בהזמין עצמו לעשות איזה מצוה או תקון ויחוד טוב לומר בפיו קודם אקרא לאלהים עליון וגו׳. ופסוק ה׳ יגמור בעדי וגו׳ שנזכרו בשתי פסוקים אלה ג׳ שמות הכוללים כל מיני שפע[v] ורב

engaging in spiritual seclusion should imagine that throughout this entire day he stands in the Garden of Eden before the Divine Presence.[1]

A lamp should be lit in the synagogue in his name to favorably remember his soul before God. Our Sages have already stated in the Talmud and Midrash Song of Songs, praising the inhabitants of the city of Usha, about the reward given to Obed-Edom for lighting a lamp before the Ark.[2] We have already discussed the mystery of the synagogue lamp in the first discourse. One who is not versed in Mishnah should extend his recitation of supplications found in the prayer books, and weave together verses from Torah to Prophets and from Prophets to Writings.

It is also appropriate for the discerning person to read the scroll of Song of Songs with proper intention on this day, as it is said there: "The Song of Songs was given to Israel solely for their praise, and therefore it should never be interpreted to their discredit"—thus Rabbi Judah said to Rabbi Meir many times.

This principle should be in one's hand at all times: when preparing to perform any commandment, rectification, or unification,[3] it is good to first recite: "I will call upon God Most High," etc., and the verse "The Lord will complete [what concerns me]," etc. These two verses mention three divine names[4] that encompass all types of abundance and goodness—El, Elohim, and YHVH—besides the hidden mysteries they contain. For this special

[1] This metaphorical instruction exemplifies the mystical orientation of Ma'avar Yabok, where physical ritual practices are meant to create corresponding spiritual states of consciousness.

[2] The connection between lamp-lighting and spiritual merit forms part of the theological foundation for the practice of memorial candles (ner neshamah) for the deceased.

[3] These three terms represent increasingly mystical levels of religious practice in Kabbalah: commandments (mitzvot) are basic religious obligations; rectifications (tikkunim) are spiritual repairs; and unifications (yichudim) are advanced kabbalistic practices of joining divine attributes.

[4] The three divine names El, Elohim, and YHVH are understood in Kabbalah to represent different divine attributes: El corresponds to Chesed (loving-kindness), Elohim to Gevurah (strength/judgment), and YHVH to Tiferet (beauty/harmony).

[i] A Hebrew idiom meaning 'to express frustration' or 'to rebuke harshly,' literally 'to throw bile at them.'

[ii] The Hebrew language, considered sacred in Jewish tradition, especially in prayer and Torah study.

[iii] Refers to the biblical account in 2 Samuel 6:11-12 where Obed-Edom was blessed for housing the Ark of the Covenant. The Talmudic tradition adds that he specifically received reward for lighting a lamp before the Ark.

[iv] A method of prayer that systematically draws verses from the three sections of the Hebrew Bible in sequence, creating a comprehensive spiritual practice.

[v] The three divine names mentioned (El, Elohim, and YHVH) are understood in Kabbalah to channel different types of divine abundance and blessing when recited with proper intention.

טוב הלא הם אל אלהים ה׳
מלבד הסודות הכמוסים שבהם
לסגולת זה אח״כ יאמר ויהי
נועם ה׳ אלהינו עלינו וגו׳ ובזה
יצליח דרכו וישכיל וכ״ש שיש
לו לישא על שפתיו פסוקים
אלו בכל שעה מהיום הנזכר
עם שאר פסוקי דרחמי כאשר
ישים ה׳ בפיו והודוי שהוא בסוף
סדר הג׳ מימים אחרונים בימי
השבוע במעירי שחר שלנו הם
מכוונים הרבה להאמר ביום
בזה. וקודם תפלת המנחה יקדים
לבית הכנסת לא פחות משעה
אחת ושם ישב בדד וידום ויחשוב
תחלה בגדולת יוצר הכל וכמה
גבהו דרכיו מדרכי בני אדם
ועם כל זה הוא בוחר בשירי
זמרה ואומר לישראל השמיעני
את קולך ואח״כ בלבבו יבין
וידע כמה הוא נבזה וגרוע ויעיר
במחשבותיו עונות נעוריו ובפרט
כל מה שפעל ועשה מיום ר״ח
שעבר עד יום ר״ח זה ויספוד
עליהם ובזה לא ייראא מימי רע
כדאמרי׳ במדרש תהלים על
פסוק למה אירא בימי רע עון
עקבי יסובניi אותם שדועכים
את העון ברגליהם בעקביהם
וכל המעביר עונו מנגד עיניו
אין הקב״ה מוחל לו לכן יקיים
וחטאתי נגדי תמידii ולפי כוון
מחשבות לבו כן יקרא בפיו
פסוקי דרחמי וסליחה ואם
ישבר לבו בקרבו וידמע אז
טוב לו ויעביר הדמעות על
מצחוiii להעביר רשמי וכתמי
העבירות ששם נרשמים. וסדרי

purpose, one should then say: "May the pleasantness of the Lord our God be upon us," etc. By doing so, one's path will prosper and succeed. How much more so should one carry these verses on one's lips every hour of the designated day, along with other verses of mercy as God places in one's mouth. The confession that appears at the end of the third order for the last days of the week in our "Me'irei Shachar" [prayer collection] is particularly appropriate to be recited on such a day.

Before the afternoon prayer, one should arrive at the synagogue no less than an hour early. There, one should sit alone in silence and first contemplate the greatness of the Creator and how elevated His ways are above human ways. Nevertheless, He desires songs of praise and says to Israel: "Let me hear your voice." Afterward, in one's heart, one should understand and know how despicable and deficient one is, and awaken in one's thoughts the sins of one's youth, particularly everything one has done from the previous new moon until this new moon, and lament over them.[1] In this way, one will not fear evil days, as explained in the Midrash on Psalms regarding the verse: "Why should I fear in days of evil? The iniquity at my heels surrounds me"—referring to those who trample iniquity with their feet, with their heels. For anyone who puts his sin out of sight, the Holy One, blessed be He, will not forgive him. Therefore, one should fulfill "my sin is always before me," and according to the direction of one's heart's thoughts, so should one recite verses of mercy and forgiveness. If one's heart breaks within and tears flow, it is good, and one should pass the tears over one's forehead[2] to remove the impressions and stains of transgressions that are recorded there.

The sequences of verses that we have arranged to be recited daily in the morning and afternoon prayers are, in our opinion, very appropriate to be recited

[1] The Hebrew 'yispod' suggests a formal, ritualized lamentation rather than mere regret, indicating a structured practice of confronting one's sins.

[2] This physical practice reflects the kabbalistic concept that the forehead (metzach) is where one's deeds are spiritually recorded, with sins leaving impressions that can be cleansed through the ritual application of tears of genuine repentance.

[i] This creative interpretation of Psalm 49:6 plays on the word 'ekev' (heel) to suggest that one should 'trample' or actively confront one's sins rather than ignore them.

[ii] From Psalm 51:5, this verse is a central principle in Jewish penitential practice, teaching that one should keep awareness of one's sins to maintain humility and motivation for improvement.

[iii] This practice reflects the kabbalistic belief that sins leave spiritual impressions on the forehead that can be cleansed through genuine tears of repentance.

הפסוקים אשר סדרנו להאמר מידי יום ביומו בשחרית ומנחה הם לדעתנו מאד מכוונים להאמר ביום רצון כזה ואפי׳ מי שאינו מרגיל עצמו בהם בכל יום ויודפסו בסוף ד׳ מאמרותינו אלה לזכות הרבים בהם אם יגזור ה׳:[i]

on such a favorable day, even for one who does not accustom himself to them daily. They will be printed at the end of these four discourses of ours to benefit the public, God willing.

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

בשעת תפלת המנחה יתריע בפה באומרו הנוסח עננו ה׳ עננו שבמחזורים כדאמור רבנן במסכת תענית בתפלת המנחה נענה אליהו[ii] ואמרי׳ במדרש מזמור קמ״א במנחה מתה נפשי עלי ומעי מתחלפין לפיכך צריך אדם להתודות חטאתו ולהתחנן בתפלת המנחה לכן נאמר משאת כפי מנחת ערב ואח״כ יתפלל מנחה עם הצבור בכוונה כפי טוהר לבו ואל יסתכל אנה ואנה בפני שום אדם ויסתיר עצמו בטליתו ואל יזוז מבית הכנסת אם אפשר לו עד

During the afternoon prayer, he should call out vocally by reciting the formula "Answer us, O LORD, answer us"[1] found in the prayer books, as the Rabbis stated in the Tractate of Ta'anit: "Elijah was answered during the afternoon prayer." And it is said in the Midrash on Psalm 141: "In the afternoon my soul faints within me and my internal organs are transformed." Therefore, one must confess one's sins and supplicate in the afternoon prayer, as it is said: "May the lifting of my hands be as the evening offering." Afterward, he should pray the afternoon prayer with the congregation with intention according to the purity of his heart, and he should not look here and there at any person, but should conceal himself in his prayer shawl. He should not move from the 5R 10R 15R

[1] This is a liturgical response called 'Anenu' that is added to the silent Amidah prayer on fast days. Its placement in the afternoon prayer is significant because according to tradition, this is when divine mercy is most accessible.

[i] Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author references his own prayer collection 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), which appears to contain specially arranged confessional prayers. He specifically mentions that the confession from the third order for the last days of the week is particularly appropriate for the day of spiritual seclusion and fasting. | Cf. Garden of Eden before the Divine Presence — This reference frames the spiritual practice being described as one that should elevate the practitioner to a state of mystical consciousness, as if they were standing in the Garden of Eden (a spiritual realm) in the direct presence of the Divine. This reinforces the mystical orientation of Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. the mystery of the synagogue lamp in the first discourse — The author is creating an internal cross-reference to his earlier writing in the first discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, where he apparently discussed the mystical significance of lighting lamps in the synagogue. This indicates the interconnected nature of the work's sections. | Cf. Obed-Edom and the Ark — The author references the biblical account of Obed-Edom, who housed the Ark of the Covenant and was blessed for it (2 Samuel 6:11-12). Here, the Talmud and Midrash are cited as teaching that Obed-Edom's reward was specifically for lighting a lamp before the Ark, emphasizing the spiritual merit of lamp-lighting as a devotional practice. | Cf. verses of mercy as God places in one's mouth — This references the biblical concept found in passages like Exodus 4:12 where God tells Moses 'I will be with your mouth and teach you what to say.' In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it suggests that during spiritual seclusion, one should be open to divine inspiration regarding which verses to recite.

[ii] This refers to the story in Tractate Ta'anit (I Kings 18) where Elijah's prayer was answered during the afternoon prayer when he challenged the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel. This established the afternoon prayer time as particularly powerful for favorable divine response.

כי יפנה כל יום הקדוש ההוא
ואז יפטר בכי טוב וילך ויאכל
בשמחה לחמו וישתה בלב טוב
יינו בסעודת החדש שהיא מצוה
ובכל פעם שירחץ ידיו יאמר
ארחץ בנקיון כפי וגו׳.[i] אך
אל יאכל אכילה גסה ויזהר
בכל תקוני השלחן גם בסעודה
ההיא בדקדוק ככתוב על ספרי
המחברים בפרט בספר ראשית
חכמה שער הקדושה ובזה יובטח
לו כי רצה אלהים את מעשיו
ביוה״כ קטן ההוא[ii] ובה יוסיף
אומץ בכל ערב ר״ח כדאמרי׳
במדרש שיר השירים מה יונה
מחדשת בכל חדש וחדש גורן כך
ישראל מחדשין בכל חדש תורה
ומעשים טובים ויזהר בחדש
הבא מריחוק עבירה יותר ממה
שנזהר בחדש עבר למען ימעטו
בעיניו תלאות נפשו בפקודת
מעשיו אחר שעבר החדש הזה וכן
ידקדק בדקדוקי מצות ותמיד
יוסיף שמן לנר. וזאת תורת
האדם הנלבב להרגיל עצמו
בכל ימי חלדו להשים אל לבו
על כל פגע ומקרה בלתי טהור
המתגולל עליו מאיזה מין שיהיה
שהכל בא לו מדין הצדק בדין
ובמשפט ישר כמו שעשו אחי יוסף
במצרים ולפי בחינת היסורין
הבאין עליו יפשפש וימשמש
במעשיו כי ודאי ימצא בו דופי
וידע נאמנה דאיהו הוא דעוית
לנפשיה ולגרמיה ומשובותיו
הם המוכיחים ומצערים אותו
לא זולת. אם נפל למשכב
בסיבת חולי כבר באו פרטים
ובחינות בזה מבוארים במאמר
ראשון בחסד אל וממשפט הזה
יבחן וידע במקרים המתחדשים
עליו מידי זמן בזמן בשאר
מיני יסורין או חיסור ממון וכן

synagogue, if possible for him, until that entire holy day has passed. Then he may depart in good spirits and go eat his bread with joy and drink his wine with a glad heart at the New Moon feast, which is a commandment. Each time he washes his hands, he should say: "I will wash my hands in innocence, etc." But he should not eat excessively, and he should be careful about all the proper table arrangements even at this meal, with precision as written in the books of the authors, particularly in Sefer Reishit Chochmah, Gate of Holiness. In this way, he will be assured that God has accepted his deeds on this Minor Yom Kippur, and thereby he will gain strength on every eve of the new month, as it is said in the Midrash on Song of Songs: "Just as a dove renews its threshing floor every month, so Israel renews Torah and good deeds every month." He should be more careful in the coming month to distance himself from transgression than he was in the past month, so that the troubles of his soul will be diminished in his eyes when his deeds are examined after this month has passed. Thus he should be meticulous in the details of commandments and always add oil to the lamp.

This is the teaching for a person of understanding: to accustom himself throughout all his days to take to heart every unpleasant encounter and impure incident that befalls him, of whatever kind it may be, that everything comes to him from righteous judgment, in straight justice and judgment, as Joseph's brothers realized in Egypt. According to the nature of the sufferings that come upon him, he should examine and search his deeds, for he will certainly find a flaw in himself. He should know with certainty that it is he who has perverted his soul and his essence, and that his backsliding is what reproves and pains him, nothing else. If he falls ill and becomes bedridden, the details and aspects of this have already been explained in the first discourse by God's kindness. From this judgment, he can examine and understand the events that occur to him from time to time in other types of suffering or financial loss, as well as all distress that arises, even if it seems trivial in his eyes, like the stubbing of his finger. It has already been

[i] This is the beginning of Psalm 26:6, which continues: "and I will go around Your altar, O LORD." It became a traditional verse to recite during ritual hand-washing.

[ii] Yom Kippur Katan (Minor Yom Kippur) was a practice instituted by 16th century kabbalists, particularly in Italy, that involved fasting and special prayers on the day before each new month (except before Tishrei, when actual Yom Kippur would soon follow).

כל צער מתחולל ואפי׳ יהיה
קטן בעיניו כנקיפת אצבעו
כבר הכריזו עליו מלמעלה כך
לסבת עונותיו כי אפי׳ צפרא
מבלעדי שמיא לא מתצד[i] כאשר
הראו להרשב״י ובנו בעת צאתם
מהמערה כדאמרי׳ בגמרין
ובמדרש רבה. וכן אל יפול
לבו עליו אם זרים אוכלים חילו
או אם קרוביו ומיודעיו ואחיו
ובית אביו מעבירים עליו את
הדרך וכל אחד מברך לעצמו
ואוכל וחדי והוא חוץ למחנה
מושבו עם גוזליו מרחף יאלם
ולא יפתח פיו כי ידע נאמנה
כי הוא חרץ לו משפטו זה
ומי יתן כי תחשב לו לתקון
מקלקול הצינורות[ii] משפע
המים המתוקים והזכים אשר
היו ראויים לבא בדרכי הנועם
מאשר הנחלים לכבודה בת מלך
פנימה דרך צנורות הקדושה
שהם אחים וקרובים ואחוזים
זה בזה ולא יתפרדו ותהום אל
תהום קורא לחבירו לקולם והוא
בחטאיו הסב השפע אחורנית ח״ו
או כי לא הרבה החלב המלובן
בתוכם כראוי לחלק נשמתו או
נפשו ורוחו אשר חנן לו אלהיו
בהתרשלו מכמה מצות ויחודים
ותקונים ואפי׳ כדהוה אפשר
ליה למעבד כפי מיעוט ידיעתו
והשגתו לא עבד על כן מודדים
לו בזה מדה כנגד מדה ויחשוב
זה לו לתקון ויכשיר מעשיו.
ובראש כלם יקדש עצמו בשעת
תשמיש. ובעונות הראויות פן

decreed upon him from above thus because of his
sins, for even a bird is not caught without Heaven's 60R
decree, as was shown to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai
and his son when they emerged from the cave, as
stated in the Talmud and Midrash Rabbah.

Similarly, he should not let his heart fall if
strangers consume his wealth, or if his relatives, 65R
acquaintances, brothers, and father's house bypass
him, with each one blessing himself and eating and
rejoicing while he remains outside the camp with
his young ones, hovering silently without opening
his mouth. For he should know with certainty 70R
that he himself has determined this judgment for
himself. Would that this might be considered for
him as a rectification for the disruption of the
channels of the sweet and pure waters that were
meant to come through pleasant paths from the 75R
cascade of streams to honor the king's daughter
within, through the channels of holiness, which
are brothers and relatives bound together without
separation, with deep calling to deep at the sound
of Your waterfalls.[1] But he, through his sins, has 80R
turned the divine flow backward, God forbid, or
because he did not increase the white milk within
them as appropriate for his soul portion, or his soul
and spirit which God graciously gave him, by being
negligent in several commandments, unifications, 85R
and rectifications. Even what was possible for
him to do according to his limited knowledge and
comprehension, he did not do. Therefore, they
measure out to him measure for measure, and he
should consider this as a rectification for himself 90R
and improve his deeds.

Chief among all these, he should sanctify himself
during marital relations.[2] And at the appropriate
times, lest, God forbid, he pour out to the garbage
and labor in vain and give birth to chaos.[3] At the 95R

[1] This poetic phrase combines kabbalistic concepts of interconnected divine channels with biblical language from Psalm 42:8. It envisions the properly functioning spiritual universe as a harmonious family where divine energies flow properly between related aspects.

[2] Jewish mystical tradition places great emphasis on the spiritual significance of marital intimacy, seeing it as a potential act of cosmic unification when performed with proper intentions and sanctity.

[3] These are euphemisms for improper emission of seed or approaching marital intimacy without

[i] This Aramaic phrase means "even a bird is not caught without Heaven's decree" and refers to the concept of divine providence extending to the smallest details of creation.

[ii] This reflects kabbalistic terminology where spiritual channels (tzinnorot) convey divine abundance. Sin is understood as causing disruption to these channels, while proper spiritual practice restores their function.

ח״ו יערה לאשפה ולא יגע לרי״ק
ולא ילד לבהל״ה ולפחות יכוין
למה שכתבנו בכוונת הזווג בסוף
מעירי שחר כי היא דרך כבושה
אפילו למאן דלא קרי ולא תני
וכל המוסיף הרי זה משובח.
ומכל הבא עליו יודה למלך
המשפט דיהיב לוה למיטרפיסיה
בהאי עלמא. ואולי בזה נתן
רמז למה שאמרו בגמרא ירמיהו
אחי העביר עלי את הדרך יאמר
שלהיות שהוא במעשיו בלתי
טובים הרים וסלק חס ושלום
תרין דודין הממתיקין דאינון
יו״ד ה״א מעל הבנים שהם ימי
הבנין והכבו״ד המקבלת מהם
הנכללים בוא״ו ה״א וזה היה
בשומעו לאחיו שהוא יצה״ר
אח לצרה יולד[i] והוא רע ומר
כי הוא מסטין ואח״כ מקטרג
ונוטל רשות ויורד זה גרם כי
העבירו מעליו את הדרך ומלת
עלי יהיה כמו בסבתי שכן הוא
הלך בדרך לא כבושה. כלל
הדברים טוב לגבר כי ישא
עול היסורין על צוארו באהבה
וביראה ובפרט כשאין בהם
ביטול תורה ותפלה כי אם יזכה
המקום ימלא חסרונו והתוספת
יהיה מרובה על העקר כדרך
ברכתו של הקב״ה כדאיתא בב״ב
פ׳ יש נוחלין בבנו של יוסף בן
יועזר דאעבריה אבוהי מנכסיה
דהוה עיליתא דדינרי. ועינא
פקיחא דלית ליה גבינין דהבט
אל עמל לא יוכל[ii] אמטי לידיה

very least, he should direct his intention according to what we wrote about the intention for marital union at the end of Me'irei Shachar, for it is a well-trodden path even for one who has not studied Scripture or Mishnah, and whoever adds to this is praiseworthy. For all that comes upon him, he should give thanks to the King of Judgment who gives the borrower what he needs to sustain himself in this world. 100R

Perhaps this provides a hint to what they said in the Talmud: "Jeremiah, my brother has bypassed me on the road." It means that because he, through his improper deeds, raised and removed—God forbid—the two beloveds who sweeten, which are Yod-Hei, from above the children, who are the days of building, and the Glory that receives from them, which are included in Vav-Hei.[1] This happened when he listened to his brother, who is the evil inclination, "a brother born for adversity," who is evil and bitter because he first entices, then accuses, then receives permission and descends. This caused them to bypass him on the road, and the word "alai" (upon me) should be understood as "because of me," for indeed he walked on an untrodden path. 105R 110R 115R

The essence of the matter is that it is good for a person to bear the yoke of sufferings upon his neck with love and reverence, especially when they do not involve neglect of Torah and prayer. For if he merits, God will fill his lack, and the addition will be greater than the original, in accordance with the Holy One's way of blessing, as found in Bava Batra, chapter "There Are Those Who Inherit," regarding the son of Joseph ben Yoezer, whose father disinherited him from his property, which was an upper chamber full of dinars. But the watchful eye that has no eyelids,[2] which cannot look upon iniquity, brought to his hand a pearl inside a fish, which was valued 120R 125R 130R

proper spiritual intentions. The Hebrew uses wordplay with biblical terms: 'lashpah' (garbage), 'la-rik' (in vain), and 'la-behalah' (for chaos/terror).

[1] This is highly technical kabbalistic language. The 'two beloveds' refer to the divine attributes of Wisdom and Understanding (Chokhmah and Binah), represented by the letters Yod and Hei of the divine name. The 'children' or 'days of building' refer to the lower six divine attributes, while 'Glory' (Kavod) refers to the attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom), represented by the final Hei. Together these make up the four-letter divine name YHVH.

[2] This is an anthropomorphic description of divine providence, emphasizing that God's oversight is constant and unblinking, particularly regarding moral judgment.

[i] This is a play on Proverbs 17:17 "A brother is born for adversity." The author reinterprets this to refer to the evil inclination (yetzer hara) as a "brother" that brings adversity.

[ii] This refers to God as "the watchful eye that has no eyelids, which cannot look upon iniquity," combining kabbalistic imagery with the biblical phrase from Habakkuk 1:13.

מרגניתא בגו ביניתא ושיימוה בתליסרי עיליתא דדינרי א״כ עליו לשבח ולהדר למלך שמיא דכל מעבדוהי קשוט ואורחיה דין כי לא לאדם דרכו על כן בסוף ימי החדש ביום שופכו נפשו לה׳ יעביר לנגד עיניו כל מאורע הן לטוב הן למוטב קטן או גדול שעבר עליו בכל ימי החדש וישים בכף שניה עונותיו ויחדש וישפר מעשיו וישוב אל בעל ההשגחה ויודה לשמו כי טוב כי לעולם חסדו ואם האיש הלזה המתבודד יחשוב בסדר זמנים מתחלת ימי החדש עד סופו כפי הכוונה אשר הצגנו במאמר ראשון יושלם כוונת טהרתו יותר בנקל וירגיש בעצמו טוהר לב ברחמי שמים בהתקדשו עצמו למטה:[i]

at thirteen upper chambers of dinars. Therefore, he should praise and glorify the King of Heaven, for all His works are truth and His ways justice, for "a man's way is not his own." Thus, at the end of the month, on the day when he pours out his soul to God, he should review before his eyes every event, whether good or bad, small or great, that has befallen him throughout the month. He should place his sins in the second pan of the scale,[1] renew and improve his deeds, return to the Master of Providence, and give thanks to His name, for He is good, for His kindness is everlasting. And if this secluded person contemplates the order of times from the beginning of the month to its end, according to the intention we presented in the first discourse, the purpose of his purification will be more easily fulfilled, and he will feel within himself purity of heart through the mercies of Heaven by sanctifying himself below.

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

הנה פתחנו פתח כחודה של מחט[ii] בתקון כולל זה ברם כל טהר ידים יוכל להוסיף אומץ על

We have opened a door as narrow as the eye of a needle[2] for this comprehensive rectification, yet anyone with pure hands can add strength to our

[1] This refers to a metaphorical weighing of one's deeds, with life events in one pan and personal sins in the other, emphasizing the importance of moral self-accounting and recognizing divine justice in one's experiences.

[2] This idiomatic expression indicates the author's humility, suggesting he has only begun to scratch the surface of this spiritual topic.

[i] Cf. Tractate of Ta'anit — The author cites this talmudic source to emphasize the special spiritual potency of the afternoon prayer time, particularly for fasting days. | Cf. Midrash on Psalm 141 — This midrashic source is used to establish the afternoon as a time of particular spiritual vulnerability and therefore an especially appropriate time for confession. | Cf. Sefer Reishit Chochmah, Gate of Holiness — The author refers readers to this ethical-kabbalistic work by Rabbi Eliyahu de Vidas for detailed instructions on maintaining proper sanctity during meals. | Cf. Midrash on Song of Songs — This midrashic source is used to establish the concept of monthly spiritual renewal, which forms the basis for the Yom Kippur Katan practice being described. | Cf. Story of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai and his son emerging from the cave — This talmudic story (from Shabbat 33b) is referenced to support the theological claim that even minor suffering is divinely ordained, as Rabbi Shimon and his son witnessed how even a bird's death was decreed from heaven. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar — The author refers to his own work 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), which apparently contains instructions for proper mystical intentions during marital relations. | Cf. Bava Batra, chapter "There Are Those Who Inherit" — This talmudic story is used to illustrate how divine providence can transform suffering into blessing, with the final reward being greater than the initial loss. | Cf. First discourse of Ma'avar Yabok — The author refers readers to his earlier discussion in the first section of Ma'avar Yabok for a more detailed explanation of illness from a theological perspective.

[ii] This phrase literally means 'like the eye of a needle' and is a rabbinic expression for something very small or narrow, indicating the author's humility about his contribution.

דברינו בכוונות עליונות בהויות
ויחודים ותקונים המזיינים
ומדשנים לנפש כפי השגת יד
כי אי אפשר לכוין דברים אלו
בכתב כי יתארכו הגליונות ודי
לנו לעורר הלבבות מהאנשים
פחותי הערך כמוני הצריכים
תקון ודאי ורמות להם חכמות.
ויכוין בתענית כפי מה שבא בזהר
פרשת שמות דף כ׳ ע״ב והסדר
הראוי לנהוג בתענית ובמה
יעסוק בהם הנה באו מפורטים
בספר ראשית חכמה בשער
הנ׳[i] וגם גורי האר״י[ii] דרשו בהם
בפרט כוונות לכל מין תענית
ביחודים הנאותים ליאמר בהם
כפי פרטי העוונות הנה הנם
צמותים בספר ראשית חכמה
הקצר ובפרט התקון הכולל
מאתים תעניות עם הכוונות
שבהם ומאן דמצי לצעוריה
נפשיה טוב לקיים אותם. מלבד
קונטריסין רבים ונחמדים אשר
הם ביד משכילי עמנו ישמרם
ה׳ ומבקשי ה׳ יבינו כל ואם
המתבודד ה׳ זה המבקש לראות
עולמו בחייו ויהיה ממשפחת
הבריאים ויוכל לטהר עצמו
בטבילה ביום שלפני התענית או
ברחיצה ט׳ קבין[iii] אם ראה קרי
או קיים מצות עונה ובקבלתו
התענית מבעוד יום לא יאכל
בשר ולא ישתה יין תענית כזה

words through higher intentions, divine names, unifications, and rectifications[1] that arm and nourish the soul according to one's capacity. It is impossible to properly direct these matters in writing, as the pages would grow too lengthy. It is enough for us to awaken the hearts of people of little worth like myself, who certainly need rectification and for whom wisdom is too lofty.

One should direct one's intention during fasting according to what appears in the Zohar, Parashat Shemot, page 20b. The proper order to follow during fasting and what one should occupy oneself with are detailed in Sefer Reishit Chochmah in the 50th Gate.[2] The disciples of the ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria) have also expounded upon them, particularly the intentions for each type of fast with the appropriate unifications to be recited according to the specific sins. These are compiled in the abridged Reishit Chochmah, especially the comprehensive rectification of two hundred fasts with their intentions. And one who is able to afflict himself[3] would do well to fulfill them.

Besides these, there are many delightful treatises in the possession of the enlightened among our people—may God protect them—and those who seek the Lord will understand everything. And if this God-fearing person who seeks to see his world during his lifetime belongs to the family of the healthy and can purify himself through immersion on the day before the fast, or by washing with nine kav of water if he experienced a nocturnal emission or fulfilled the marital obligation,[4] and accepts the fast while it is still day, not eating meat

[1] This refers to kabbalistic practices of meditation on divine names (kavvanot) and spiritual unifications (yichudim) that are central to Lurianic mysticism.

[2] Reishit Chochmah (Beginning of Wisdom) by Rabbi Elijah de Vidas was a major kabbalistic ethical work that systematized mystical practices for spiritual self-improvement.

[3] This refers to someone physically capable of undertaking extensive fasting as a spiritual discipline without endangering their health.

[4] These conditions require ritual purification before engaging in sacred activities according to Jewish law.

[i] Reishit Chochmah (Beginning of Wisdom) is a significant kabbalistic ethical work written by Rabbi Elijah de Vidas, a student of Moses Cordovero. The '50th Gate' likely refers to a section dealing with spiritual purification through fasting and related practices.

[ii] This refers to the disciples of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the ARI), the preeminent 16th-century kabbalist whose teachings revolutionized Jewish mysticism. His disciples systematized and spread his teachings throughout the Jewish world.

[iii] Nine kav of water is a prescribed amount for ritual purification when full immersion in a mikveh (ritual bath) is not possible. This measurement is discussed in Talmudic literature as an alternative form of purification.

יועיל לשלשה עשר תעניות כמו שבא בקונטרס אחד של החכם סרוק זצ״ל.[i] ועכ״פ יפרוש מתשמיש בליל תעניתו וטוב שירחץ מעט לפחות במקומות המטונפים שטהרה מביאה לידי קדושה כלל הדברים כל כ״ו שעות אלו[ii] יהיה תמיד לבו למעלה ועיניו למטה ולא ידבר דבור חול ככל האפשר לו ורובו של יום לפחות ישב לעצמו כי עקר גדול לתקון זה הוא התבודדות ותמיד יכניס אהבת ויראת שמים בלבו ויקדש מחשבותיו ורעיונותיו ככל האפשר לו. ובן כל מי שירא לנפשו מפני חלום רע או מפגע רע או משטן המשחית או משום איזה מקרה בלתי טהור פן יאונה אליו רעה כבר הוזהר במאמר המלך החכם כי ברוב חלומות והבלים ודברים הרבה כי את האלהים ירא ואמרו במדרש קהלת דף ע״ו ע״ב אמר רבי אם ראית חלומות קשין וחזיונות קשים והפוכין או שאתה מתייראי מהן קפוץ לשלשה דברים ואתה ניצל מהם דא״ר יודן בשם ר״א ג׳ דברים מבטלין גזירות רעות ואלו הם תפלה צדקה ותשובה רבי מונא אמר אף התענית דכתיב יענך ה׳ ביום צרה וכן אמרו בגמרין במס׳ ראש השנה. ובהנהגה זו כלהו אתנהו ביה ואמרו במדרש תהלים מזמור ק״ד אם זכית מלאכי שלום

nor drinking wine—such a fast will be effective as thirteen fasts,[1] as is written in one treatise by the sage Rabbi Israel Sarug of blessed memory.

In any case, he should abstain from marital relations on the night of his fast, and it is good that he wash a little, at least in the unclean places, for purity leads to holiness. In short, throughout these twenty-six hours,[2] his heart should always be directed upward while his eyes are lowered, and he should not speak secular words as much as possible. For most of the day, at least, he should sit alone, as the primary foundation for this rectification is solitude.[3] He should always instill love and fear of Heaven in his heart and sanctify his thoughts and reflections as much as possible.

Similarly, anyone who fears for his soul because of a bad dream, or a harmful incident, or from the destructive adversary, or because of some impure occurrence, lest evil befall him—he has already been warned by the statement of the wise king: "For in the multitude of dreams and futilities and many words, fear God." And they said in Midrash Kohelet, page 76b: Rabbi said, "If you see difficult dreams and difficult and disturbing visions, or if you fear them, leap to three things and you will be saved from them." For Rabbi Yudan said in the name of Rabbi Eliezer, "Three things nullify evil decrees,[4] and they are: prayer, charity, and repentance." Rabbi Muna said, "Also fasting, as it is written: 'May the Lord answer you in the day of trouble,'" and so they said in our Gemara in Tractate Rosh Hashanah.

In this practice, all of these are included, and they said in Midrash Tehillim, Psalm 104: "If you merit, angels of peace will guard you, and no evil will touch you, as it is said: 'No evil will befall you.'" Therefore, one should accustom oneself to solitude for several

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic principle that proper intention and preparation multiplies the spiritual efficacy of religious observances.

[2] The number 26 is significant in Kabbalah as the numerical value of the divine name YHVH, suggesting that this extended fast period has cosmic significance.

[3] Hitbodedut (spiritual seclusion) became particularly important in post-Lurianic Kabbalah as a means of achieving mystical communion.

[4] This rabbinic teaching appears in the Talmud (Rosh Hashanah 16b) and is fundamental to Jewish approaches to averting divine punishment.

[i] This refers to Rabbi Israel Sarug, a contemporary and possibly a student of Isaac Luria, who spread Lurianic Kabbalah throughout Italy. The acronym זצ״ל means 'of blessed memory.'

[ii] The reference to 26 hours indicates an extended fast that begins before sunset on one day and continues until after nightfall the following day, with the number 26 also having mystical significance as the numerical value of the divine name YHVH.

משמרין אותך ואין נוגע בך דבר
רע שנאמר לא תאונה אליך רעה
ע״כ ירגיל עצמו בהתבודדות
קצת שעות מהיום על הדרך
הנזכר או ירבה בימים כאלו
כמו יום אחד לשבוע. ואם
יתענה סך תעניות הלא טוב
לו ליחד אחת מהם בראשיתם
ובסופם בהתבודד לעצמו עם כל
התקונים האלו ובזה יוסיפו עליו
אומץ מלמעלה וכבר נמצאו
בתקוני גורי האר״י המודפסים
כי בתקון יום א׳ יוכל אדם
להציל נפשו מכרת א׳ ואפי׳
באכול די מחיתו יע״ש וכ״ש אם
יוסיף בו התענית והתבודדות
ואם יהיה יום ששי בזה יזכה
לשתים להכין עצמו לחזות
בנועם ה׳ ולבקר בהיכלו לקבל
אור ג׳ שבתות.[i] שבת מלכתא.
ושבת הגדול. והשבת המתווך
ביניהם.[ii] להאיר נפשו רוחו
ונשמתו באור שבת שהוא מעין
העולם הבא ואז יקרא וה׳ יענהו
ולא יירא משוד כי יבא ויהיה
מוצק וישכון בטח ורענן ויתענג
על רב שלום ויזכה למה שאמרו
במדרש תהלים מזמור קי״ד בשם
פנחס הכהן בר חמא הרקיע
ששמו מרבות[iii] הקב״ה זורע
מעשיהם של צדיקים עליו והוא

hours of the day as mentioned, or increase such days to one day a week.

And if one fasts a number of fasts, it would be good to dedicate one of them at their beginning and their end to solitude with all these rectifications, and thereby strength will be added to him from above. It has already been found in the published rectifications of the ARI's disciples that through the rectification of one day, a person can save his soul from one spiritual excision,[1] even while eating sufficient for his livelihood—see there—and all the more so if he adds fasting and solitude. And if it is Friday, he will merit two things: to prepare himself to behold the pleasantness of the Lord and to visit His palace, to receive the light of three Sabbaths—the Sabbath Queen, the Great Sabbath, and the Sabbath that mediates between them[2]—to illuminate his soul, spirit, and higher soul with the Sabbath light, which is a foretaste of the World to Come.[3]

Then he will call and the Lord will answer him, and he will not fear when destruction comes. He will be firmly established and dwell securely and fresh, and delight in abundant peace. He will merit what they said in Midrash Tehillim, Psalm 114, in the name of Pinchas the Priest, son of Hama: "The firmament whose name is Aravot[4]—the Holy One, blessed be He, sows the deeds of the righteous upon it, and it produces fruit."

And the order of this fast will be like what they said in Midrash Shir HaShirim about an apple:[5] when you place an issar coin in it, you can

[1] Karet (spiritual excision) is considered one of the most severe spiritual penalties in Jewish tradition, referring to the soul being 'cut off' from its divine source.
[2] This reflects a kabbalistic understanding of Sabbath as having multiple spiritual dimensions that correspond to different aspects of divine reality.
[3] This reflects the rabbinic concept that Sabbath provides a glimpse of the messianic future, with its perfect rest and spiritual harmony.
[4] In rabbinic cosmology, Aravot is the seventh and highest heaven, where the divine throne is located and where the souls and deeds of the righteous are preserved.
[5] This refers to a rabbinic parable that illustrates how a small investment (the issar coin) can

[i] The 'three Sabbaths' mentioned likely correspond to the three levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah) that are illuminated through proper Sabbath observance, particularly when preceded by spiritual preparation.
[ii] This describes three mystical aspects of Sabbath: 'Sabbath Queen' refers to the feminine divine presence that arrives on Sabbath; 'Great Sabbath' may refer to either the Sabbath before Passover or a cosmic spiritual level; while the 'mediating Sabbath' suggests an intermediate aspect connecting the other two.
[iii] According to rabbinic tradition, there are seven heavens, with Aravot (מרבות) being the highest. This highest heaven is where God is described as residing and where the souls of the righteous and their deeds are stored.

עושה פירות. וסדר התענית
זה יהיה ע״ד שאמרו במדרש
שיר השירים על תפוח שאתה
נותן בו איסר[i] ומריח בו כמה
ריחות וכן אמר משה לישראל
במצרים בדבר קל אתם נגאלים
כן ביום א׳ בחדש הבעל תשובה
יזכה ויחיה ויראה בטוב וישב
בקתדרא בג״ע כפי המשל המובא
במדרש קהלת דף ע״ג ע״א על
פסוק מה יתרון העושה ואמרו
במדרש תהלים דף מ״ג אמר
הקב״ה מי שישרתני בעה״ז הוא
ישרתני לעה״ב ועתיד הקב״ה
לעשות פיהם של צדיקים לעתיד
לבא כמעיין נובע[ii] שאונו פוסק
שם דף מ״ד. ומצוה קלה שהיא
בכאיסר אמרה תורה למען ייטב
לך והארכת ימים והעושה מצוה
זאת כתקנה מובטח אני כי תנתן
לו נפשו כמה דאמרו במשנה
פ״ג דמכות העושה מצוה אחת
על אחת כמה וכמה שתנתן לו
נפשו:[iii]

smell many fragrances. And thus Moses said to Israel in Egypt: "Through a simple matter you will be redeemed." Similarly, on one day in the month, the penitent will merit and live and see goodness and sit in a chair in the Garden of Eden, according to the parable brought in Midrash Kohelet, page 73a, on the verse "What profit has the worker?"

And they said in Midrash Tehillim, page 43: "The Holy One, blessed be He, said: 'Whoever serves Me in this world will serve Me in the World to Come.'" And in the future, the Holy One, blessed be He, will make the mouths of the righteous like a flowing spring that never stops,[1] as mentioned there on page 44. And regarding a minor commandment worth merely an issar coin, the Torah states: "That it may be well with you, and you may prolong your days." And one who performs this commandment properly, I am assured that his soul will be given to him, as they said in the Mishnah, Chapter 3 of Makkot: "One who performs a single commandment—how much more so will his soul be given to him."

105R 110R 115R 120R 125R

yield disproportionate benefits (many fragrances), similar to how a small spiritual action can have immense spiritual impact.

[1] This messianic image describes how in the World to Come, the righteous will effortlessly generate Torah insights, unlike in this world where wisdom requires great effort.

[i] An issar was a small coin of minimal value in Talmudic times, used here metaphorically to represent a small investment that yields significant returns, similar to how a minor spiritual practice can produce major spiritual benefits.

[ii] This is a messianic image describing how in the World to Come, the righteous will become fountains of divine wisdom, continuously generating new insights without effort, unlike in this world where Torah study requires great effort.

[iii] Cf. The Zohar, Parashat Shemot, page 20b — The author cites this passage from the Zohar to establish authoritative guidance on the spiritual intentions (kavvanot) required during fasting practices. The Zohar was the foundational text of Jewish mysticism, so this reference establishes the kabbalistic framework for the practices being discussed. | Cf. Sefer Reishit Chochmah — This reference to Elijah de Vidas' influential 16th-century kabbalistic ethical work indicates that the practices being described are not innovations but rather are rooted in established mystical literature. Reishit Chochmah systematized Lurianic Kabbalah into ethical practices, making it a practical resource for the rituals described here. | Cf. Writings of Rabbi Israel Sarug — This reference to a treatise by Rabbi Israel Sarug (a contemporary and possibly student of Isaac Luria) helps establish the author's intellectual lineage within Lurianic Kabbalah. Sarug was known for systematizing and spreading Lurianic teachings throughout Italy, suggesting this reference serves to legitimize the efficacy of the fasting practices described. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 5:6 — The citation of "the wise king" (Solomon) regarding dreams and futilities serves as biblical authority for the seriousness of spiritual dangers. This scriptural reference establishes that even seemingly minor spiritual disturbances (like bad dreams) should be addressed through religious practices. | Cf. Midrash Kohelet (on Ecclesiastes) — This rabbinic source is cited to provide detailed guidance on the remedies for bad dreams and spiritual dangers, specifically identifying prayer, charity, repentance, and fasting as the solutions. This reference establishes the traditional rabbinic basis for the

פרק ה׳

Chapter 5

הנהגה לבריאים לשמור בריאותם.[i] וגם לחולה שיחשב צערו וישוב אל יי בכל לבו[ii] [iii]

The regimen for the healthy to maintain their health.[B] And also for the sick person who should consider his suffering and return to the LORD with all his heart[1]

ההנהגה ביסורין שהן בגוף האדם כמו החולאים יש מהם שיתהוו משטות בני האדם כגון

Guidance for afflictions of the body such as illnesses: Some arise from human folly, like exposure to cold or traps. This resembles one who kills himself and 5R

[B]Or: "A guide for the healthy to preserve their well-being" — This alternate translation captures the instructional nature of 'hanhagah' as a guide rather than just a regimen, and uses 'well-being' which has a more holistic connotation that might better reflect the integrated physical-spiritual approach of the text.

[1]This phrase connects physical health to spiritual repentance (teshuvah), reflecting the book's consistent theme that proper physical care must be accompanied by spiritual rectification. The author establishes that what follows will integrate medical advice with religious obligation.

mystical practices being recommended. | Cf. Psalm 20:2 — This biblical verse is cited to specifically support the efficacy of fasting as a remedy for spiritual dangers, connecting the concept of "the day of trouble" with fasting practices. | Cf. Tractate Rosh Hashanah — This reference to the Talmud serves to establish that the practices being described are not merely kabbalistic innovations but have roots in classical rabbinic literature, giving them broader authority. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim on Psalm 104 — This midrashic source is cited to describe the spiritual benefits of the practices being recommended, specifically divine protection from harm. The reference to "angels of peace" suggests the creation of a protective spiritual environment through these practices. | Cf. Psalm 91:10 — This biblical verse reinforces the protective aspect of the spiritual practices, showing that proper observance of these rituals creates divine protection from harm. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim on Psalm 114 — This reference explains the cosmic significance of righteous deeds, describing how they are metaphorically "sown" in the highest heaven (Aravot) and produce spiritual fruit. This establishes the broader cosmological framework in which these spiritual practices operate. | Cf. Midrash Shir HaShirim (on Song of Songs) — This reference uses the metaphor of an apple and a coin to illustrate how a seemingly small spiritual action can produce disproportionately large spiritual benefits, supporting the author's claim about the efficacy of even a single day of spiritual practice. | Cf. Midrash Kohelet (on Ecclesiastes), page 73a — This reference elaborates on the spiritual rewards awaiting those who engage in the practices described, specifically placement in the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim, page 43-44 — This reference emphasizes the continuity between religious service in this world and the next, suggesting that the spiritual practices described create lasting relationships with the divine that extend beyond death. | Cf. Deuteronomy 22:7 — This biblical verse (from the commandment to send away a mother bird before taking its young) is cited to demonstrate that even seemingly minor commandments bring significant rewards, supporting the author's claim about the efficacy of the practices described. | Cf. Mishnah Makkot, Chapter 3 — This rabbinic source is cited to reinforce the principle that performing even a single commandment properly brings significant spiritual rewards, supporting the author's argument about the value of the spiritual practices described.

[i]This section appears to begin a regimen for maintaining health, consistent with the early modern Jewish medical-spiritual approach that viewed physical wellbeing as connected to spiritual state.

[ii]The Hebrew phrase 'yashuv el HaShem' (return to the LORD) uses the language of teshuvah (repentance), establishing the theological framework that physical health and spiritual repentance are interconnected.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse — This heading builds on the theological framework established in the first discourse, where suffering is presented not as random misfortune but as purposeful divine correction that provides an opportunity for spiritual growth and return to God. | Cf. Deuteronomy 30:2 — The phrase 'return to the LORD with all his heart' echoes the biblical concept of teshuvah (repentance) found in Deuteronomy 30:2, which states 'And you shall return to the LORD your God and obey His voice... with all your heart and with all your soul.'

צנים פחים[i] וזה דומה להורג את עצמו שעתיד ליתן את הדין וכן המחליא עצמו מפני היותו רודף אחר תאוותיו ובכלל זה מי שאינו משתדל ברפואה עצמה בכלל חוטאים יחשב ואם בטל העבודה בסבת החולי גם את דמו מידו ידרושו. אמנם יש חולאים רעים ונאמנים מצד הבורא לסבת עון ואלו חייב אדם לרדוף אחר הרפואה כזורע בארץ בבטחון הבורא ע״י איש פלוני ע״י סם פלוני שמא זהו האיש זהו הסם זהו הזמן. ויש מהן שמלפפין האדם עד יום מיתה הכל גזור מלמעלה כדי רשעתו במספר לא יגרע ולא יוסיף וצעקו מדוד ומשוער לא יעדיף ולא יגרע הכל ברצון גבוה. אפי׳ פזור הממון בחילי עד שיעור פלוני כאשר כתבנו בחלק ראשון בשפ״ת צדק. ויש יסורין בני עון והם יסורי אהבה[ii] ועם כל זה תחלתם בדין כנסיון ה׳ על מעשה העגל וכאיוב וכיוצא אמנם סופם אהבה. ויש שכלם אהבה גמורה ואלו הם יסורין של שכר ודאי ועין פירוש מהו צדיק בן צדיק וסוד יסורי אהבה וע״ז אמרו בגמרא לא הם ולא שכרם והם להצלת הרבים שלא יקטרג השטן עליהם כי השכינה הנקרא אהבה פעמים יש בה דין מחמת מעשה הדור ומשפעת אותו דין על הצדיק כדי להטריד השטן ולא יקטרג הרבים. וכל מי שמצדיק על עצמו דין שמים גורם שמדת הגבורה מתתקנת בקבלת האדם על עצמו באהבה דין זה וזהו סוד צדוק הדין כאשר כתבנו בח״ב שפת״י צד״ק של אמ״ת. ולפעמים יגרום דין זה ממש מיתה והיינו בעין מיתת

will be held accountable. Similarly, one who makes himself ill by pursuing his desires, or who fails to seek proper medical treatment, is counted among sinners. If one neglects divine service due to illness, his very blood will be required of him. 10R

However, there are severe and persistent illnesses sent by the Creator as punishment for sin. For these, one must pursue healing like a farmer who sows the earth with trust in the Creator—perhaps through this particular person, this remedy, at this time. Some afflictions cling to a person until death, all decreed from above according to one's wickedness—neither more nor less than the prescribed measure. One's cry of pain is calculated and measured, neither exceeding nor falling short, all according to the divine will. Even the expenditure of money for healing is predetermined to a specific amount, as we wrote in the first section, "Lips of Righteousness." 15R 20R 25R

There are afflictions born of sin that are nevertheless "afflictions of love." Though they begin as judgment—like God's test after the sin of the Golden Calf, or like Job's trials—they ultimately stem from love. Then there are those that are entirely expressions of love; these are afflictions that bring certain reward. Consider the explanation of what makes "a righteous person the child of a righteous person" and the mystery of "afflictions of love," about which our Sages said, "Neither they nor their reward," meaning they exist to protect the community from Satan's accusations. For the Divine Presence, called "Love," sometimes contains judgment due to the generation's deeds, channeling that judgment onto the righteous person to distract Satan from accusing the many. 30R 35R 40R

Anyone who justifies divine judgment upon himself causes the attribute of Strength to be rectified through his loving acceptance of this judgment. This is the secret of Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment), as we wrote in the second part, "Lips of Righteousness of Truth." Sometimes this judgment actually causes death, similar to the atoning deaths of the righteous. See more about this in Parashat Vayeshev, page 180a. This is why we read about the death of Aaron's sons on Yom Kippur as atonement 45R 50R

[i] This refers to Proverbs 22:5, "Thorns and snares are in the way of the perverse," but is interpreted here as physical dangers that can be avoided with proper caution.

[ii] The concept of 'afflictions of love' (yissurei ahavah) comes from Talmudic discussions (Berakhot 5a) about sufferings that are not punishments but divinely sent to increase one's reward in the world to come.

הצדיקים המכפרת[i] וכיוצא.
ועיין מזה בפ׳ וישב דף ק״פ
ע״א. ולכן אמרו שקורין בצבור
ביום הכפורים מיתת בני אהרן
לכפרתן של ישראל כי מלאכם
שהוא מזלם למעלה מלבד זכות
נשמתם מתעורר בזה לבקש
רחמים על ישראל ומיתתן
מכפרת להם שכן נקדש הבית
במיתתן וזכו כל ישראל בזה
והצדיקים זוכים ומזכים בג״ע
מעין מה שתקנו ועשו בעה״ז
כאשר כתבתי בחלק ג׳ הנקרא
שפת״י רננו״ת. ואותו הצדיק
המכפר על הדור נשכר ונוטל
כנגד כל אותן שנעשה מזבח
כפרה עליהם כעין רבי עקיבא
וחביריו חלקם בחיים כדאמרו
כך עלה במחשבה שכוונתם
במיתה זו עלה להתייחד נפשו
במחשבה אשר עין לא ראתה ומי
שזכה למה שדרשו יושבי בשבת
תחכמוני על אשריך רבי עקיבא
שיצתה נשמתך באחד[ii] יבין
גודל מעלתו. וביסורי אהבה
של הצדיק יתוקן שאלת צדיק
ורע לו[iii] מלבד כמה טעמים
אחרים ועיין בפ׳ וישב דף ק״פ
מהות יסורין של אהבה הנה
כי הכל במדה ובמשקל והצד
השוה לאדם שלעולם בכל מעשיו
ופעולותיו יתקשר בקדושה
העליונה כפי השפעתה אם חסד
חסד ואם דין דין ואם רחמים
רחמים. והמדה אשר היא שולטת
ביום כאשר כתבנו בחלק שפת״י
צד״ק כל סדר הזמנים דבר יום
ביומו בלילה שולט אותה ספירה
עצמה ברם היא למטה במלכות
הנקראת ממשלת הלילה וביום
יכוין למעלה בקומה סוד ת״ת

for Israel, because their angel, which is their mazal above, apart from the merit of their souls, is aroused by this to seek mercy for Israel. Their death atones for them, as the Temple was sanctified through their death, and all Israel gained merit thereby. The righteous merit and bring merit to others in the Garden of Eden, reflecting what they established and accomplished in this world, as I wrote in the third section called "Lips of Joyous Song."

The righteous person who atones for the generation is rewarded and receives compensation for all those for whom he became an altar of atonement, like Rabbi Akiva and his companions, "whose portion is in life." As the Sages said, "Thus it arose in thought"—meaning their intention in this death was to unite their soul with the divine thought that no eye has seen. One who understands what the Sages expounded regarding "those who dwell in counsel" concerning "Happy are you, Rabbi Akiva, that your soul departed with 'One'" will comprehend the greatness of his level.

Through the "afflictions of love" of the righteous, the question of "why the righteous suffer" is resolved, besides several other reasons. See Parashat Vayeshev, page 180, for the nature of "afflictions of love." Indeed, everything is measured and weighed, and the common principle for all people is that in all actions and deeds, one should connect to the supernal holiness according to its influence—if kindness, then kindness; if judgment, then judgment; if mercy, then mercy.

The divine attribute that governs during the day, as we wrote in the "Lips of Righteousness" section regarding the order of times, continues to rule at night, but below in Malkhut, which is called "the dominion of night." During the day, one should direct one's intention upward to the structure of Tiferet, which is adorned with its six extremities and called "the dominion of day." One should always perform the rectification appropriate to the governing attribute, following the pattern of "evening, morning, and noon

[i] The Talmud (Moed Katan 28a) states that the deaths of the righteous atone for the sins of the generation, similar to sacrificial offerings.

[ii] This refers to the Talmudic account (Berakhot 61b) of Rabbi Akiva's martyrdom, where he recited the Shema prayer during his execution, extending the word 'One' (echad) until his soul departed with that word.

[iii] This addresses the theological problem of why the righteous suffer, a question discussed extensively in rabbinic literature, particularly in relation to the book of Job.

המתפאר בשש קצותיו[i] הנקרא
ממשלת היום ולעולם יעשה
התקון המתייחס להנהגה ההיא
השולטת על דרך ערב ובקר
וצהרים אשיחה ואהמה וישמע
קולי ובזה לא יחסר עיטור
השכינה מעל ראשו לעולם ויהיה
דבק במלכו כי אשרי כל חוסי
בו וכבר כתבנו בח״ד הלז עת״ר
ענ״ן הקטר״ת בפרק ראשון כח
נשמתו של אדם ואחיזתו בקדושה
העליונה כי בידו ובכחו לגדל
ולחזק לכל וכל אשר יקרא בשם
ה׳ ימלט:[ii]

I will meditate and moan, and He will hear my voice." In this way, the crown of the Divine Presence will never depart from one's head, and one will cleave to one's King, for "happy are all who take refuge in Him." We have already written in the fourth section of this work, "Cloud of Incense Prayer," in the first chapter, about the power of a person's soul and its connection to supernal holiness, for it is in his hand and power to magnify and strengthen everything, and whoever calls upon the name of the LORD will be saved.

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

פה אציע לפניכם בני אשר
הבנתי מדרושי ודברי חכמים
מהו הסבה הגורמת שפעמים
ח״ו קם איש על רעהו ורצחו
נפש בלא מרמה עשה ועל לא
חמס בכפיו לכאורה. להודיע
ולהודע כי משפטי ה׳ אמת
צדקו יחדו ושאין האדם הרוצח
ממית אלא ערוד ממית שהוא
החטא[iii] ברם מ״מ מלתא כבר
אמורה וגם רשע ליום רעה ואין
למוכה אלא להצדיק דין שמים

Here I will present to you, my children, what I have understood from the discourses and words of the sages regarding the cause that sometimes, Heaven forbid, a person rises against his fellow and kills him without apparent deceit or violence. This is to make known and to be known that the judgments of the LORD are true and righteous together, and that it is not the murderer who kills, but rather the serpent that kills—which is sin. Nevertheless, it has already been said that "the wicked is reserved for the day of evil," and the victim has no choice but to accept divine judgment upon himself and not attribute all

[i] This is a kabbalistic reference to Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), the central sefirah that balances between Chesed (Kindness) and Gevurah (Strength) and is associated with six directions or extremities.

[ii] Cf. Lips of Righteousness (Siftei Tzedek) — The author refers to the first section of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on proper care for the sick and dying. This cross-reference shows how the current passage on types of suffering relates to the broader structure of the book. | Cf. Lips of Joyous Song (Siftei Renanot) — The author cites the third section of his own work, which contains prayers and meditations. This self-referential structure shows how the author wants readers to see connections between different parts of Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Cloud of Incense Prayer (Eter Anan HaKetoret) — The author refers to the fourth section of his work, which focuses on prayer as a substitute for Temple incense offerings. This cross-reference demonstrates how the current passage on connecting to divine attributes relates to the prayer practices described elsewhere in the book. | Cf. Parashat Vayeshev, page 180a — The author refers to a specific passage in the Zohar on Parashat Vayeshev that discusses 'afflictions of love.' This shows how the author grounds his theological framework in kabbalistic sources. | Cf. Death of Aaron's sons — The author references the biblical account of the deaths of Nadab and Abihu, Aaron's sons, which is read during the Yom Kippur service. This illustrates how their deaths serve as atonement for Israel. | Cf. Rabbi Akiva's martyrdom — The reference to Rabbi Akiva's soul departing with 'One' alludes to the Talmudic account of his martyrdom, where he recited the Shema prayer as he was being executed, drawing out the word 'One' (echad) until his soul departed.

[iii] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Berakhot 33a) that "it is not the serpent that kills, but sin that kills," suggesting that murder is part of a divine plan in which the murderer serves as an instrument of judgment.

עליו ולא לתלות כל הקלקלה
ברוצח כי היה שבט עבר״תו
רק שתלו הקלקלה במקולקל
ולעולם אינו יוצא משפט מעוקל.
לא ישתוה עונש שופכי דמים זה
לזה יש מי שאינו ראוי להוליד
בנים או זקן וזקנה ויש נשמה
הגונה להוליד כמה מיני נשמות
ומשפחות גדולות וא״כ יש שופך
דמים שמחריב עולם מלא ויש
מי שמחריב נפש אחת וזה אינו
גלוי אלא לפני בורא הכל. יש
עוד בנים נפשיים מצות רבות
שהיה עושה שכלן הם בנים אל
הנשמה והיא תביעה רבה כי הרג
ומנע אותה היחודים והתקונים
שהם הבנים שהיה ראוי להוליד
כדדרשו דמו ודם זרעותיו[i] כי
כללו במיעוט דבריהם אלה
כל מה שאמרנו וזו היא תביעת
הגופים שהיה בכחו להולידם
והיו מקבלים תקון כנדרש אצלנו
במקום אחר ואפי׳ יתוקנו אותם
הנשמות שהיו עתידים להתלבש
באותם הגופים כי ודאי לא ידח
מהם נדח גם להם יש תביעה על
ההורג כי מתעכב תקונם ויהיה
בסבובים אחרים הקשה להם
וכל זה צעקה רבה על ההורג
או מצד המצות או מצד התורה
שזו אבדה שאינה חוזרת לעולם.
גם הימים שהנשמה מתקשטת
בהם בעולם כענין ויקרבו ימי
ישראל למות והרבה כיוצא שהם
מתהוים לבוש להתלבש האדם
בהם וכאשר לא השלים ימיו אינו
שלם בלבושו וחסר ימיו ושנותיו
ואלו הם דמי לשון רבים כלם
צועקים ולזה אמר החכם אדם
עשוק בדם נפש עד בור ינוס אל
יתמכו בו שעון שפיכות דמים
גדול עד למאוד ופוגם במקום
שאין הפה יכולה לדבר והמבין
לאשורו שופך דם האדם באדם
דמו ישפך ילבש חרדה ויאחז

the corruption to the murderer, for the murderer was merely the rod of His wrath. The corruption is attributed to the corrupted one, and divine justice is never distorted.

The punishment for bloodshed is not equal in all cases. There are those who are not fit to bear children, such as the elderly, and there are worthy souls meant to produce many types of souls and large families. Thus, there is one who sheds blood and destroys an entire world, and there is one who destroys only a single soul—this is revealed only to the Creator of all.

There are also spiritual children—the many commandments one would have performed, all of which are children to the soul. This is a great claim against the murderer, for he has killed and prevented those unifications and rectifications—the children that should have been born—as the sages interpreted "his blood and the blood of his descendants." For they included in these few words everything we have said. This is the claim of the bodies that could have been born through the victim and would have received rectification, as we have explained elsewhere. Even if those souls that were destined to clothe themselves in those bodies will be rectified—for surely none of them will be cast away—they still have a claim against the killer, because their rectification is delayed and will occur through other, more difficult cycles. All this is a great outcry against the murderer, whether from the perspective of lost commandments or lost Torah study, which is a loss that can never be recovered.

Moreover, the days with which the soul adorns itself in this world, as in "the days of Israel drew near to die" and many similar phrases, become garments in which a person clothes himself. When one does not complete his days, he is incomplete in his garment, lacking his days and years. These are the "bloods" [in plural form]—all of them cry out. Therefore, the wise man said: "A man oppressed by the blood of a soul will flee to the pit; let no one support him"—for the sin of bloodshed is exceedingly great and damages a place that the mouth cannot speak of. One who truly understands "whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed" will be clothed in

[i] This refers to the rabbinic interpretation of Genesis 4:10, where God tells Cain that his brother's 'bloods' (plural) cry out. The Mishnah (Sanhedrin 4:5) explains this plurality as referring to Abel's blood and the blood of his potential descendants.

בשרו פלצות מחמת התגברות
הדינים קדושים וחצונים ועזים
ופועלי און בכל ארבע מדרגות
אבי״ע.[i] ואם המית רשע שהיה
עתיד לחזור בתשובה זו רעה
כפולה ומכופלת שהרג נשמה עם
הגוף שאם נתקנה נשמה זו עם
הגוף היה עושה מצותיו ומשלים
משנתו ותורתו והיה עולה לאביו
שבשמים ועתה בסבת הרוצח
אינה עולה למעלה אלא עומדת
למטה עד תשו״ב ותשלים ותעלה
ולזה יאמר קול דמי אחיך
צועקים אלי מן האדמה לא
עלתה לפני לצעוק אלא צועקים
אלי מן האדמה דוקא.[ii] עוד יש
בכלל צעקת הנרצח שיעור צער
המיתה שאולי היה עתיד למות
בלא כ״כ צער כמשחל ביניתא
מחלבא[iii] ועתה נצטער בהיות
וקם עליו להרגו שניה תחלת
הפציעה שהוא מכה ופצוע עד
שמגיע הצער מדרגה אחר מדרגה
עד שהגיע אל צער עקירת
הנפש והחיים מן הגוף ובזה
ישתנה הענין כפי הדרך שהרגו
כמו שיוכל להבחין בזה טבע
האדם ושכלו וזהו דמי אחיך
יהיו פציעותיו וצער המיתה
כל אותו צער צועק תמיד על
ההורג ודאי. מלבד כי מסלק
החיות מהמדות העליונות מעל
התחתונות רחמנא ליצלן וזהו
קול מצד ת״ת והרוח והיצירה
צועקים אל״י תהיה הבינה שהיא
אם כמספר אל״י היא הנשמה
והבריאה מן האדמה מדת מלכות
האדומה והנפש היא העשיה
אחיך הגוף והעשיה גשמית כל
אלו משתתפים בסוד הצעקה
ראה כמה כובדו של עון זה.

trembling, and his flesh will be seized with shuddering because of the intensification of holy and external judgments, fierce ones and evildoers in all four levels of ABYA [Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah]. 60R

If he killed a wicked person who was destined to repent, this is a doubled and multiplied evil, for he has killed a soul along with a body. Had this soul been rectified with the body, it would have performed its commandments and completed its Mishnah and Torah study, and would have ascended to its Father in heaven. Now, because of the murderer, it does not ascend upward but remains below until it repents, completes its work, and ascends. This is why Scripture says: "The voice of your brother's bloods cry out to Me from the ground"—they did not rise before Me to cry out, but rather they cry out to Me specifically from the ground. 65R 70R

The victim's outcry also includes the measure of the pain of death, for perhaps he was destined to die without such suffering, like drawing a fish from milk, but now he suffers as the murderer rises against him. Second, there is the initial wounding, being struck and wounded, until the pain progresses from one level to another, reaching the pain of uprooting the soul and life from the body. This varies according to the manner in which he was killed, as human nature and intellect can discern. Thus, "your brother's bloods"—his wounds and the pain of death—all that suffering continually cries out against the murderer. 75R 80R 85R

Furthermore, the murderer removes the vitality from the higher attributes above the lower ones, God forbid. This is the voice from the side of Tiferet, and the spirit, and Yetzirah cry out to "ELI" [God], which is Binah, which is the Mother, with the numerical value of "ELI," which is the Neshamah and Beriah. "From the ground" is the attribute of Malkhut, the reddish earth, and the Nefesh is Asiyah. "Your brother" is the body and physical Asiyah. All these participate in the mystery of the outcry—see how grave this sin is. 90R 95R

Sometimes the Holy One, blessed be He, sus-

[i] ABYA is an acronym for the four spiritual worlds in Kabbalah: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action). The author suggests that murder causes damage across all four cosmic planes.

[ii] Emphasizing that the souls of murder victims are trapped at the level of Malkhut (represented by 'adamah'/earth) rather than ascending to higher spiritual realms, causing them to cry out specifically 'from the ground.'

[iii] A Talmudic expression (Berakhot 8a) describing an easy death, literally 'like drawing a fish from milk'—a metaphor for a peaceful, painless extraction of the soul from the body.

ופעמים הקב״ה מעמיד הרוצח
100 גם אחר החטא מפני שיש בו צורך
לעולם כשהיה בקין כי צדקת
הצדיק עומדת לבסוף וכן רשעת
הרשע והרשעים רואים ומחשבים
בלבם שאין להורג עונש ונקמה
105 ולא ידעו כי הנהגתו ית׳ תלויה
במחשבתו העליונה אשר לא
ידעה אלא הוא בעצמו ואנו
משיגים אותו אחר המיתה כמו
שהיה בהריגת למך לקין.[i] ועונש
110 הרוצח נכלל בו חרם נדוי שמתא
וזהו ארור אתה מן האדמה שבו
כל מציאות קללה ונדוי מפי
עליון רחמנא לישזבן:[ii]

tains the murderer even after the sin because he
serves a purpose in the world, as was the case with 100R
Cain, for the righteousness of the righteous stands
in the end, as does the wickedness of the wicked.
The wicked see and calculate in their hearts that
there is no punishment or vengeance for the mur-
derer, not knowing that His conduct, blessed be He, 105R
depends on His supernal thought, which only He
Himself knows. We comprehend it only after death,
as in the case of Lamech killing Cain. The pun-
ishment of the murderer includes excommunication,
banishment, and anathema, which is "cursed are you 110R
from the ground"—containing all forms of curse and
excommunication from the Supreme One. May the
Merciful One save us!"

פרק ז׳

Chapter 7

שיתו לבבכם לחילה ודעו כי
הנהרגים אינם נהרגים בלי
עון ח״ו[iii] שאין לבריה עליונה
ותחתונה שליטה להרוג שום
5 נפש אלא ע״י חיות עליון
אמת שמגלגלים חובה על ידי
חייב[iv] באשר אמרנו. וטעם
למה ילקה זה שהרגו בקללות
נמרצת בשני עולמות ובמיני

Set your heart to her ramparts and know that those
who are killed are not killed without sin, God for-
bid, for no creature above or below has authority to
kill any soul except through the true supernal life-
force, which brings about guilt through the guilty, 5R
as we have said. And the reason why the one who
killed suffers intense curses in both worlds and vari-
ous evil punishments—these things you should seek
out in the books of the LORD and read, and you

[i] According to Jewish tradition (Genesis Rabbah 23:4), Lamech accidentally killed his ancestor Cain. This is used here as an example of delayed divine justice, as Cain was eventually punished for Abel's murder through Lamech.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 4:10-15 — The author uses this biblical narrative to demonstrate that sometimes murderers are kept alive by divine providence for a purpose, and that judgment may be delayed but ultimately comes, as seen in Lamech later killing Cain. | Cf. Proverbs 28:17 — This biblical verse is used to demonstrate that murder is such a severe sin that the murderer is beyond help and will inevitably face judgment. | Cf. Genesis 9:6 — This verse is cited to show the cosmic principle of measure-for-measure justice that applies to murder, emphasizing that this justice operates across all spiritual worlds. | Cf. Proverbs 11:19 — The verse is used to explain the sometimes delayed nature of divine justice, which may not be immediately visible but is nevertheless assured. | Cf. Genesis 49:1 — This biblical phrase is interpreted mystically to suggest that a person's allotted days become spiritual garments for the soul, and when life is cut short, these garments remain incomplete. | Cf. Talmud Sanhedrin 4:5 — This reference expands the concept to suggest that the severity of murder varies according to the potential of the victim—some souls might have produced many descendants or accomplished many good deeds. | Cf. Zohar on the four worlds (ABYA) — Murder is presented as a sin that damages all four spiritual worlds (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah), showing how a physical act has repercussions throughout the cosmic structure of reality.

[iii] The text presents a complex theological position that victims of murder must have some sin that makes them vulnerable to death, yet simultaneously maintains that murderers are fully culpable for their actions. This apparent tension reflects the kabbalistic understanding that divine justice operates through multiple layers of causality.

[iv] This phrase expresses the rabbinic principle that 'God brings about guilt through the guilty' (מגלגלין חובה על ידי חייב), found in Talmud Shabbat 32a, suggesting that divine justice operates through human agency rather than direct intervention.

עונשים רעים אלו דרשו מעל
ספרי ה׳ וקראו ותדעו נאמנה כי
פעמים יש עון שהאדם מתחייב
בו מיתה ואין הפתקא נמסרת
ליד החצונים ואין להם רשות
לשלוט בו ויודעים הם בחובו של
זה אלא שהגזרה העליונה אינה
רוצה למסור בידם הכח כלל
ורוצה הקב״ה להרחיב לו ואם
הקב״ה תלה לקין כל הדורות
החם למה לא יתלה להבל הצדיק
שלא היה עונו רק שהציץ לבד
כדפירשו חז״ל עד אשר יתקן
את אשר עוה אלא שיש עונות
שהם תלויים עד ישקיף וירא ה׳
משמים מה יעשה ואינו נמסר
ביד החצונים ובזה נבין מאמר
הואי כשגגה היוצאת מלפני
השליט והרבה הנהגות הדומים
לזה כיון שרואה החצוני כך
מבקש לו דרכים אחרים והולך
אחר הרשעים שהם מתנהגים
ע״פ עצתו ומגלגל להם עילות
גשמיות ממש ומביאם לידי יצה״ר
עד שיביאו המיתה ויגלו הסתום
ויקרבו הרחוק ואלו לא נמצאו
הסבות הגשמיות ההם מעולם
לא היה בא המיתה שם מפני
שאינו חפץ גבוה אמנם ס״מ יש
לו רשות להחטיא בני אדם ולתת
בלבם כל רעה שבעולם מגלגל
גלגולים עד שבסבות דקות
וקלושות יבעיר אש מחלוקת בין
בני אדם ואלו היו כובשים את
יצרם מעולם לא היה בם אש
מחלוקת ובזה לא תעשה מחשבתו
ויגורשו הרשעים מהעולם דהיינו
ס״מ ולילית[i] אמנם הרשעים
נותנים להם מצד מזגם הרע
לינה במגורם בקרבם ואז מעורר
להם מדנים חמדת ממון או אבק
לשון הרע או לשון הרע בעצמו
או קללות ובזויים וחרופים
כי נבל הוא ונבלה ידבר ומיד
מורה להם סבות קלות גשמיות

will faithfully know that sometimes there is a sin for 10R
which a person deserves death, yet the decree is not
delivered into the hands of the external forces, and
they have no permission to rule over him. They know
of this person's guilt, but the supernal decree does
not wish to deliver the power into their hands at all, 15R
for the Holy One, blessed be He, wishes to extend
mercy to him. And if the Holy One, blessed be He,
suspended Cain's punishment for all those genera-
tions, why would He not suspend punishment for the
righteous Abel, whose only sin was that he merely 20R
gazed improperly, as our Sages of blessed memory ex-
plained, until he rectifies what he distorted? Rather,
there are sins that remain suspended until the LORD
looks down and sees from heaven what one will do,
and they are not delivered into the hands of the ex- 25R
ternal forces. With this we can understand the state-
ment, "It happened like an error proceeding from the
ruler," and many similar patterns of divine gover-
nance.

When the external force sees this, it seeks other 30R
ways and pursues the wicked who conduct themselves
according to its counsel. It brings about actual phys-
ical causes and leads them to the evil inclination un-
til they bring about death, revealing what was con-
cealed and bringing near what was distant. And if 35R
these physical causes had not appeared, death would
never have come there, because it is not the divine
desire. However, Samael has permission to cause
people to sin and to put all the evil in the world
into their hearts. It brings about circumstances un- 40R
til, through subtle and tenuous causes, it ignites the
fire of discord between people. And if they had con-
quered their inclination, there would never have been
a fire of discord among them, and thus his [Samael's]
intention would not be fulfilled, and the wicked ones 45R
of the world, namely Samael and Lilith, would be
banished. However, the wicked give them lodging
in their dwelling, within them, because of their evil
temperament. Then it arouses strife among them:
desire for money, the dust of evil speech, or evil 50R
speech itself, or curses, contempt, and insults, for
"the villain is vile and speaks villainy," and immedi-
ately it shows them trivial physical causes that bring
death.

[i] These are references to Samael and Lilith, negative spiritual entities in kabbalistic literature who are often portrayed as a demonic couple that causes harm in the world. The text presents them as working through human agents to bring about negative events.

ומביאות המות. נמצא זה שלט
בו המיתה בעונו הטמון כדכתיב
טמון בארץ חבלו[i] לא רצתה מדת
המלכות לגלות חבל אחיזתו
וגזירת המיתה עליו ח״ו אלא
רצתה להרחיב לו הדרך אמנם
מלכודתו עלי נתיב דהיינו
המחשבה העליונה על ידי אלו
הסבות הרחוקות מבית דין עליון
הקרובות ע״י לילית וס״מ כי
המחשבה העליונה רואה כי
טוב המות לזה כי היא יודעת
סופי הדברים בסוד תקון נשמה
וגוף זה גם שמחשבה התחתונה
מלכות היתה חפצה בהארכה
כדי שישוב בתשובה הוא בעצמו
המחשבה העליונה צופה יותר
למרחוק ולהגיע עדיה בסוד
התקון האחרון ראו המות לזה
עתה לטוב לו באחריתו. ע״כ
נתן רשות לס״מ לסבב סבובים
ע״י לבות אנשים זדים ארורים
ומפתה לבם ויצרם בדברים
קלים ומביאם לידי רציחה
ולפעמים המחשבה העליונה
אין בה ונצול רק נפצע ופעמים
מלכודתו ע״י נתיב ונהרג והרי
אלו לא היה נהרג ע״י הרשע
הזה לא היה נהרג כלל שהרי
טמון היה באר״ץ חבלו והיה
אפשר למוחקו בתשובה א״כ
הרשע הזה גרם כל מה שגרם
והכל נעשה מאתו לכן ראוי
שיכרת ויענש וכל ההנהגות
שבמחשבה העליונה הם לאורך
ימים ושנים ומתקן הנהרג. ראה
כמה תולדות קין נולדו בעולם
ושת לא נולד עד ק״ל שנה
לאדם[ii] מפני שלא ינוח שבט
הרשע על גורל הצדיקים ואחר
כך כל תולדות קין כליון חרוץ
ומשת יושתת העולם כרמז ועפר
אחר יקח ווהו תחת הבל כי

Thus, death has power over this person through his hidden sin, as it is written, "Hidden in the earth is his snare." The attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom) did not wish to reveal the cord of his connection and the decree of death upon him, God forbid, but rather wished to extend the path for him. However, "his trap is upon the path"—that is, the supernal thought through these causes which are remote from the supernal court but close by means of Lilith and Samael. For the supernal thought sees that death is good for this person, as it knows the final outcome through the mystery of the rectification of this soul and body, even though the lower thought, Malkhut, desired to extend [his life] so that he might repent on his own. The supernal thought sees further and, to reach him through the mystery of the final rectification, deemed death for him now to be good for him in his end.

Therefore, it gave permission to Samael to bring about circumstances through the hearts of wicked, accursed people, enticing their hearts and inclinations with trivial matters and bringing them to murder. Sometimes the supernal thought is not involved and he is saved, merely wounded, while at other times his trap is upon the path and he is killed. And behold, if he had not been killed by this wicked person, he would not have been killed at all, for "hidden in the earth was his snare," and it would have been possible to erase it through repentance. Therefore, this wicked person caused all that he caused, and everything was done by him. That is why he deserves to be cut off and punished. And all the patterns of governance in the supernal thought are for length of days and years, and they rectify the one who was killed.

See how many descendants of Cain were born in the world, yet Seth was not born until the 130th year of Adam, so that the rod of wickedness would not rest upon the lot of the righteous. Afterward, all the descendants of Cain were utterly destroyed, while from Seth the world was founded, as hinted in the verse, "And dust shall he take of another kind," which means "in place of Abel, for Cain killed him."

[i] This is a quote from Job 18:10, referring to hidden snares. In this context, it metaphorically describes how a person's sins may remain hidden but still make them vulnerable to divine judgment, though this judgment might be delayed through divine mercy.

[ii] The text interprets the 130-year gap between Abel's death and Seth's birth (Genesis 5:3) as evidence of divine justice working across generations. It suggests that Seth (representing renewed righteousness) could not enter the world until Abel was avenged.

הרגו קין ועד שנתנקם הבל מקין
לא בא שת לעולם ועמד זעקת
הבל לפניו ק״ל שנה. עד כי
נסבל קין בעולם ולעולם הבל
זעק ולא נח מזעקתו ולא בא
שת עד שנהרג קין. ומטעם זה
יהיה אמרם שנשמת הנהרג תלויה
ועומדת בנקמה ולכך נקרא
גואל הדם הנוקם[i] שכמו שהמיבם
נקרא גואל וכיוצא או דודו בן
דודו יגאלנו כן הנוקם נקרא
גואל שע״י הנקימה גואל אותו
מצרתו למעלה שמצר ומעוכב
וזועק מן האדמה עד יתנקם
ואח״כ ישוב לימי עלומיו. ברם
מצוה רבה על כל אשר בידו
כח לגרשו ולהדיחו מעל הארץ
ההיא ולא ישוב עוד לביתו
ולא יכיר עוד מקומו והמשתדל
להחזירו נקרא עבריין[ii] ועתיד
ליתן את הדין ובי דינא רבא
יתפרע מיניה ובשעתו ובמקומו
ויחוס על עני ואביון ויגדור כל
פרצות עמו ישראל ברחמיו אל
אלהים חילי ישמע מהיכלו קולי
עם כל הנלוים עמי ויסיר לב
האבן מבשרנו ויוציאנו מאפלה
לאורה ונאמר לפניו הללויה
עם כל העדה קדושה ובשפה
ברורה נשירה ונזמרה גבורתו
וחסד ואמת יקדמו פנינו ויהי
ה׳ אלהינו עמנו אל יעזבנו ואל
יטשנו להטות לבבנו אליו ונלכה
באורחותיו לעדי עד אמן כן יהי
רצון:[iii]

Until Abel was avenged from Cain, Seth did not come into the world, and Abel's cry stood before Him for 130 years, until Cain was endured in the world. And forever, Abel cried out and did not rest from his cry, and Seth did not come until Cain was killed. 100R

For this reason, they say that the soul of the murdered remains suspended and waiting for vengeance. Therefore, the avenger of blood is called a "redeemer," just as the one who performs levirate marriage is called a "redeemer," as is a relative—"his uncle or his cousin shall redeem him." Similarly, the avenger is called a "redeemer" because through vengeance he redeems the murdered person from his distress above, where he is constrained and hindered and cries out from the ground until he is avenged. Afterward, he returns to the days of his youth. 105R 110R

Nevertheless, it is a great mitzvah upon anyone who has the power to expel and banish [the murderer] from that land, so that he shall not return again to his house, nor shall his place be recognized anymore. One who endeavors to bring him back is called a transgressor and will have to give an accounting in the future, and the great court will exact payment from him in his time and place. May [God] have compassion on the poor and needy, and may He fence in all the breaches of His people Israel in His mercy. May God, my strength, hear my voice from His sanctuary, along with all who accompany me. May He remove the heart of stone from our flesh and bring us from darkness to light. Let us say before Him "Hallelujah" with all the holy congregation, and with clear speech let us sing and chant of His might. May kindness and truth go before us, and may the LORD our God be with us. May He not forsake us nor abandon us, to incline our hearts to Him, and 115R 120R 125R 130R

[i] The 'avenger of blood' (go'el ha-dam) is a biblical concept (Numbers 35:19) referring to a relative who avenges a murder. The text reinterprets this as a spiritual 'redemption' that releases the soul of the victim from its state of distress in the afterlife.

[ii] The author takes a strong stance that anyone who helps a murderer return to the community is considered a transgressor who will face divine judgment, emphasizing communal responsibility for upholding justice.

[iii] Cf. Genesis 4 — The author uses this biblical narrative to explore the metaphysical dimensions of murder, examining why a murderer is punished even though the victim's death may have been divinely ordained due to their own sins. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 10:5 — The author uses this verse to support his theological framework that some deaths may appear accidental or unjust but are actually part of a divine plan. | Cf. Psalm 24:7 — The author alludes to this psalm in his closing prayer, using its language of divine presence to express hope for redemption. | Cf. Isaiah 32:6 — Used to characterize how evil forces operate through wicked people, instigating harmful speech and actions. | Cf. Psalm 85:11 — The author adapts this psalm in his closing prayer, asking for divine attributes to go before the people. | Cf. Job 18:10 — Used metaphorically to describe

may we walk in His ways forever and ever, Amen, may it be His will.

נשלם חלק שני ממאמר רביעי הנקרא קרבן תענית [i]

The second part of the fourth discourse, called "Sacrifice of Fasting," is now completed. 135R

how a person's sins may be hidden but still make them vulnerable to divine judgment. | Cf. Zohar, various sections on Samael and Lilith — The author draws on kabbalistic demonology to explain how evil forces operate in the world, using human agents to bring about events that fulfill divine judgments.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This concluding statement marks the end of the second part of the fourth discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, titled 'Korban Ta'anit' (Sacrifice of Fasting). This section has focused on spiritual practices centered around fasting, solitude, and proper intentions as substitutes for Temple sacrifices, presented as a system for purifying the soul and sweetening divine judgments. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part One of the Fourth Discourse — This concluding formula parallels the end of the first part of the fourth discourse, which was titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer). Both parts present spiritual substitutes for Temple offerings, with the first focused on prayer as incense and this second part focused on fasting as sacrifice.

Discourse 8

מנחת אהרן / Offering of Aharon

פרק א׳

חלק שלישי

שמעה עמי ואדברה ישראל
ואעידה בך במנחת אהרן
ההולכת לפניך[i] המעידה
ומגידה כי עשה אלהים את
ישר וכל פעל למענהו ואפי׳
יצה״ר שבו קדוש יאמר לו
והוה מעטרא ליה כסאסא ליה
לשבולתא[ii] אלא שהמה בקשו
חשבונות רבים מרבים הבל שיש
בו חטא ואדם ביקר בל ילין
עד כי קרובים נעשו רחוקים
וסלעים נעשו גבוהים בארבעה
אבות נזיקין[iii] ומשים שלום
בבית כמעט בטל וזאת תורת
האדם שחב בשמירתו להתחייב

Chapter 1

Part Three

Hear me, my people, and I shall speak; Israel, I shall testify to you through Aaron's offering that goes before you, testifying and declaring that God has made mankind upright, and all His works are for His own purpose—even the evil inclination within man, of which one may say it is holy, for it adorns him like the husk adorns the grain. Yet people have sought out many schemes, multiplying vanity that contains sin.[1] Man in his glory does not endure, until those who were close have become distant and rocky heights have become insurmountable due to the four principal categories of damages,[2] and the establishment of peace in the household has almost ceased. This is the law of mankind: one who has failed in his guardianship becomes liable to make restitution for

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'marbim hevel sheyesh bo chet' has layers of meaning. It alludes to Ecclesiastes' theme of vanity/futility while suggesting that humans complicate their existence with sinful pursuits.

[2] The author draws on legal terminology from the Talmud (the four primary categories of damages) to create a spiritual metaphor for moral failings that create distance between people.

[i] The phrase 'Aaron's offering that goes before you' is likely a reference to the author's own work, creating a wordplay between his name (Aaron Berechia) and the biblical Aaron who offered sacrifices.

[ii] This Aramaic expression compares the evil inclination to the husk of grain, suggesting that even something seemingly negative has a protective or supportive function.

[iii] This refers to the four principal categories of damages enumerated in Talmudic law (Bava Kamma): the ox, the pit, fire, and a person's own body. Here they are used metaphorically for spiritual or moral damages.

בתשלומי נזקו בהשלמת שפתיו
בפרי תורה ותהלה ועבודה
שבלב וינהיר נהוריה יום וליל
בשרנא ואורה דאורייתא כי נר
מצוה ותורה אור[i] ואם יזכה
ליהנות מתבלין זה ואורח זו ילך
אשר גזר עליו המלך ישאב מים
בששון ממעיני הישועה ויתהפכו
ארבע מראות נגעים[ii] לתענוגים
ויציאות והכנסות מעולם שכלו
שבת[iii] מתנה טובה שבבית גנזיו
של יוצר האדם בצלמו ובדמות
תבניתו. ובכנף רננים אלו
יתעלה באברה ונוצה להתקשר
במעדנות כימה[iv] וים עליון ישים
כמרקחה ואת כל גבוה יראה: [v]

his damage through the offering of his lips, with the fruit of Torah, praise, and service of the heart.[1] May his light shine day and night[2] with the lamp and light of Torah, for "the commandment is a lamp and Torah is light." If he merits to benefit from this spice and follow this path which the King has decreed for him, he will draw water with joy from the wells of salvation, and the four appearances of afflictions will be transformed into delights.[3] And there will be departures and entrances from a world that is entirely Sabbath—a good gift from the treasure house of the Creator who formed humanity in His image and likeness. With these wings of song,[4] he will be elevated with feather and plume to be bound in the delights of Orion, and he will make the upper sea like a mixture of perfume, and he will behold all that is lofty.

כמו שהחיות הגשמי נגדר בשלשה
דברים. הנה הם חומר וצורה
והעדר. כן החיות השכלי נחלק

Just as physical life is defined by three elements—matter, form, and absence—so too intellectual life is divided into three types: potential intellect, acquired

[1]This threefold expression refers to three forms of divine service: study of Torah, verbal praise/prayer, and devotional intention ('service of the heart'), which together form the basis of religious practice.
[2]The original uses Aramaic 'v'yanhir nehoreh' (and may his light shine), switching from Hebrew to Aramaic to evoke the language of the Zohar and other mystical texts.
[3]This represents a mystical inversion where spiritual afflictions become sources of pleasure, reflecting the kabbalistic concept that judgment (din) can be transformed into mercy (rachamim) through proper spiritual practice.
[4]The imagery of wings (kanaf renanim) comes from Job 39:13 and is repurposed here to represent mystical ascent through prayer and song.

[i]A direct quotation from Proverbs 6:23, 'For the commandment is a lamp and the teaching is light,' which was a common metaphor in rabbinic literature for spiritual illumination.
[ii]This refers to the four types of tzara'at (often mistranslated as leprosy) described in Leviticus, which were understood in rabbinic tradition as divine punishments for moral failures, particularly slander.
[iii]A reference to the rabbinic concept of 'the world to come' as 'a world that is entirely Sabbath'—a state of perfect spiritual rest and communion with the divine.
[iv]The word 'kimah' refers to the Pleiades star cluster (sometimes translated as Orion). In Jewish mystical thought, celestial bodies often represent spiritual entities or realms.
[v]Cf. Psalms 50:7 — The opening phrase 'Hear me, my people, and I shall speak; Israel, I shall testify to you' directly echoes Psalms 50:7, establishing this text as a solemn testimony or exhortation in the prophetic tradition. | Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — The quote 'the commandment is a lamp and Torah is light' establishes Torah study as the primary means of spiritual illumination, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to spiritual preparation. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 7:29 — The phrase 'God has made mankind upright, but they have sought out many schemes' references Ecclesiastes 7:29, suggesting that human complications and moral failings are deviations from divine design rather than inherent to human nature. | Cf. Isaiah 12:3 — The phrase 'draw water with joy from the wells of salvation' quotes Isaiah 12:3, connecting the spiritual transformations described in Ma'avar Yabok with prophetic visions of redemption and divine blessing. | Cf. Zohar on Leviticus, Metzora — The concept of transforming afflictions (nega'im) into pleasures parallels Zoharic teachings that spiritual purification can transform judgment into mercy, a key kabbalistic principle that informs Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness and death.

לג׳ שכל היולי. שכל נקנה. שכל נאצל.[i] שכל היולי. בו יפעל האדם המלאכות הראויות לו כפי טבע הרכבת חומרו. שכל נקנה. בו יתעצם האדם במדות ויתנועע למעלות הנאותות לצורתו. שכל נאצל הוא מה שיורהו התורה שנאצלה מלמעלה בהיא גברת כל ההשכלות ובה יגבר האדם על כל ההויות ויפשוט צורה וילבש צורה נאה הימנה. שזוהי דרך ההעדר אל מציאות חשוב אשר הזמן סרסור בדבר. הרי שחיות האדם הוא רוח שכלי מרחף על פני הנפש ומצייר צורתה ואינו רוח מגשמי הגדל בחיק הגוף. כי הרוח שכלי עצם. והרוח גשמי מקרה. והדבור שהוא גדר האדם ראיה לזה כי הוא פועל הנפש השכלית. וכשהדבור מצד השכל הטבעי לבד הנקרא היולי. אין בו ממש. רק הוא בקול הברת הבעל חי. וכשהוא בשכל הנקנה בזה יקרא דבור אדם. וכשהוא בשכל נאצל הוא דבור אלהים. כי דבר ה׳ אתו. הנה כי יש באדם כח להיות כמלאך וגם להיות כשטן כפי פנייתו ליצר טוב שהוא שכל וליצר הרע שהוא סכל. ונרמז במלת אמ״ש אדם מלאך שטן.[ii] ולהיות כי יש בנפש כח להעצים חיל בהשכלתה לכן

intellect, and emanated intellect.[A] With potential intellect, a person performs tasks appropriate to their physical nature. With acquired intellect, a person develops moral character and progresses toward excellence suited to their form. Emanated intellect is what the Torah teaches, having emanated from above as the mistress of all intellectual achievements; through it, a person masters all forms of existence, shedding one form to don a more beautiful one. This is the path from absence to meaningful existence, with time serving as the intermediary.

Thus, human vitality is an intellectual spirit that hovers over the soul, shaping its form—not a materialistic spirit growing within the body's embrace. For intellectual spirit is essence, while physical spirit is merely accidental. Speech, which defines humanity, proves this, as it is the product of the intellectual soul. When speech stems only from natural intellect (called potential), it has no substance, being merely like the sound a creature makes. When it comes from acquired intellect, it is called human speech. But when it flows from emanated intellect, it becomes divine speech, for "the word of the LORD is with him."

Indeed, a person has the capacity to be like an angel or like Satan, depending on whether they turn toward the good inclination, which is intellect, or the evil inclination, which is foolishness.[1] This is alluded to in the word AMSh (אמ״ש), an acronym for Adam-Malach-Satan[2] (human-angel-devil). Since the soul has the power to strengthen itself through intellectual development, it enters a body to actualize its potential and acquire new vessels through which to

[A] Or: "hylic intellect, acquired intellect, and emanated intellect" — The term 'היולי' (hylic) is a technical philosophical term derived from Greek philosophy. While 'potential' captures its meaning, preserving the technical term might be preferred in a scholarly translation.

[1] The author creates a striking equation between the good inclination and intellect (שכל/sechel) and between the evil inclination and foolishness (סכל/sachel), playing on the similar Hebrew sounds while making a profound philosophical point about the nature of moral choice.

[2] This acronym represents the author's understanding of human potential as existing between angelic and demonic possibilities. Interestingly, א-מ-ש (alef-mem-shin) are also the three 'mother letters' in Sefer Yetzirah, a foundational kabbalistic text, suggesting deeper connections.

[i] These three categories of intellect derive from medieval Jewish philosophical traditions influenced by Aristotle and Arabic commentators. The 'hylic' or potential intellect refers to the basic capacity for thought; the 'acquired' intellect refers to knowledge actually attained; and the 'emanated' intellect refers to divine wisdom received from above.

[ii] This is a kabbalistic wordplay where the Hebrew letters א-מ-ש (alef-mem-shin) are interpreted as an acronym for אדם-מלאך-שטן (Adam-Malach-Satan), representing human potential to become either angelic or demonic based on spiritual choices.

היא באה בגוף להשכיל בפועל
ולקנות כלים חדשים בפועל
השכלותיה. וזאת תורת האדם
להשכיל בנפשו כל המושכלות
אשר הוכנו לו מדברי התורה
תמימה אשר בה תוציא הנפש
כחה לפועל ההשכלה ובזה
התייפה בעה״ז ותתכבד לעה״ב.
ובג״ע ג״כ מצד פועל השכלתה
אשר תביא עמה דברים חדשים
ונאים. והחכמים בבואם בג״ע
מפארים ומייפים אותו וכל חכם
לב בהם ישמח בחכם הבא אצלם
וגם שאין לך כל צדיק וצדיק
שאין לו מדור בפני עצמו שם
כדאמרי׳ בגמ׳ מציעא פרק ז׳
ובשבת פכ״ג הוכיחו זה מפסוק
כי הולך האדם אל בית עולמו.
מכל מקום בבא הצדיק למדורו
למעונו תרבה הארה אלהית
בכל הג״ע. ומיתת הצדיק הוא
הדור אל הישיבה של מעלה
במה שיוליכו שם דברים חדשים
המתבקשים תמיד. וזהו פירוש
נתבקש בישיבה של מעלה שכל
אדם יש לו חלק בתורה ואין אדם
נוגע במוכן לזולתו לחדש מה
שצפון לחבירו וגדולים צדיקים
במיתתן יותר מבחייהם כי אז
הם מחדשים בתורה הקדושה
מעין מה שחדשו למטה בנובלת
החכמה. ובגמרא מנחות פרק ה׳
על פסוק זית רענן יפה פרי תואר
אמרו מה זית זה אחריתו בסופו
ופרש״י כי מתבשל בסופו יחד
אף ישראל אחריתן בסופן. מלבד
הנדרש במאמר ראשון בטעם
ירידת הנשמות בעולם עוד נוסיף
פה הודעה לכל משכיל דורש
בהודיע כי החצונים אין בריאתם
לריק ולבטלה כמו שהקליפה
לאילן היא יופיו וטובו[i] כדפי׳

express its intellect. This is the Torah of humanity: to comprehend through one's soul all the intelligible concepts prepared for it from the perfect Torah, through which the soul brings its potential into actual understanding. In this way, the soul becomes beautiful in this world and honored in the World to Come.

Even in the Garden of Eden, the soul brings with it new and beautiful insights derived from its intellectual activity. When sages enter the Garden of Eden, they glorify and beautify it, and every wise-hearted person among them rejoices in the wise newcomer. Although each righteous person has their own separate dwelling place there, as stated in Bava Metzia chapter 7 and in Shabbat chapter 23 (derived from the verse "when a person goes to his eternal home"), nevertheless, when a righteous person enters their dwelling place, divine illumination increases throughout the Garden of Eden.

The death of the righteous is a return to the heavenly academy, where they bring new insights that are always sought after. This explains the phrase "he was requested in the heavenly academy"—for each person has their portion in Torah, and no one infringes upon what is prepared for another by revealing what is reserved for their fellow. The righteous are greater in death than in life, for then they innovate in the holy Torah, similar to what they created below through the "fallen fruit of wisdom." In Tractate Menachot chapter 5, commenting on the verse "a leafy olive tree, beautiful in form and fruit," they said: "Just as this olive tree ripens fully at its end"—and Rashi explains that it ripens completely at the end—"so too Israel's ultimate destiny is in their end."

Beyond what was explained in the first discourse about the reason for souls' descent into the world, we add here information for every discerning seeker, explaining that the external forces[A] were not created in vain or for naught. Just as a tree's bark is its beauty and goodness, as explained in the Zohar on Parshat Tzav regarding the verse "I saw that wisdom

[A] Or: "the chitzonim" — The term 'chitzonim' is a technical kabbalistic term referring to negative spiritual forces. While 'external forces' conveys the meaning, preserving the transliterated technical term might be preferred in scholarly contexts.

[i] This presents an unusually positive view of the kelipah (shell/husk), which in many kabbalistic texts represents evil or impurity. Here, the author interprets even negative elements as serving a positive function in the divine plan.

בזהר פ׳ צו בפסוק וראיתי אני
שיש יתרון לחכמה מן הסכלות
וכו׳. ע״כ ברא הקב״ה אדה״ר
ביצה״ר בתחלת בריאתו והיתה
עצה מאתו להשכירו על טוב
מעלליו לתת חלק בנפשו מאותה
הקליפה שהיא קליפת האילן.
וזה אף אם לא יחטא אדה״ר
היה בו החלק ההוא. וזה אמת
בלי ספק שאל״כ לא היה לו
שכר בפעולתו וזה בענין הכסף
הנקי והטהור שיצטרף ויתלבן
ע״י ערוב העופרת ויתעלה עוד
עניינו כי בטוב טבעו היותו
בוחר בטוב ומואס ברע ישבור
הרע ההוא עד כי יחזירנו אל
מקומו ויצרפהו. וזהו שאמרו
בזהר תרומה במשל הזונה[i] שגם
אל הזונה יש שכר ומעלה כשאין
בן השר נפתה אחריה. כי כמו
שהוא מגביר יצה״ט שהוא ימין
מצד הקדושה כן מגביר הימין
על השמאל ואף גם החצונים
יתענגו על רב שלום כי יתלבנו
ויצטרפו עד יכנסו אל מקורם
ויתוקן הרע. וזה אחד מהתכליות
עקריות להמציא בעולם צורת
האדם למען תהיה בעולם
התחתון הוי״ה דקה קדושה
ורוחניות לתקן כח הגבורה
החזקה ודיני אף המתפשטים
לחוץ בזולת טעמים אחרים.
וזהו טוב היצ״הר שנעשה יצר
הטוב כדפי׳ בזהר כמו שהשמאל
גבורה נעשה ימין בסוד כללותה
בימין כך יצר הרע בהיותו
נכלל ביצר טוב נעשה יצר
טוב מימין ונשכר בג״ע בעידון
הנפש בנזכר. כמה רב גובריה

has an advantage over folly," the Holy One, blessed be He, created Adam with an evil inclination from the beginning of his creation. It was His plan to reward him for his good deeds by giving his soul a portion of that "shell," which is the shell of the tree. 115R
Even if Adam had not sinned, he would have had this portion. This is undoubtedly true, for otherwise he would have received no reward for his actions.

This is comparable to pure silver being refined and whitened through mixing with lead, elevating 120R
it further. For it is in humanity's good nature to choose good and reject evil, thereby breaking that evil until returning it to its place and refining it. This is what they said in the Zohar on Terumah in the parable of the harlot—that even the harlot receives 125R
reward and elevation when the prince's son resists her temptation. Just as one strengthens the good inclination, which is the right side of holiness, so too one strengthens the right over the left. Even the external forces will delight in abundant peace when 130R
they are whitened and refined until they enter their source and the evil is corrected.

This is one of the primary purposes for creating human form in the world: so that in the lower world there would be a refined, holy, spiritual existence to 135R
rectify the power of stern judgment and the fierce judgments that extend outward, apart from other reasons. This is the good of the evil inclination that becomes the good inclination, as explained in the Zohar—just as the left (severity) becomes right when 140R
included within the right, so too the evil inclination, when included within the good inclination, becomes a good inclination from the right side and is rewarded in the Garden of Eden with the soul's delight,[1] as mentioned. 145R

How great is the power and strength of one who overcomes his inclination! For in doing so, he becomes a chariot for the power of holiness[2] in its aspect that breaks the jaws of wickedness, as stated

[1] The author presents an intellectualized conception of heavenly reward, where the pleasures of the Garden of Eden consist primarily of intellectual and spiritual delights rather than physical pleasures. This reflects the influence of Maimonidean rationalism on kabbalistic thought.

[2] The concept of becoming a 'chariot' (merkavah) for divine forces is a fundamental mystical idea derived from Ezekiel's vision. Here it suggests that by overcoming one's evil inclination, a person becomes a vehicle for divine presence in the world.

[i] This refers to a parable in the Zohar where a king tests his son by sending a harlot to tempt him. When the son resists, both he and the harlot are rewarded. This parable is used to explain how the evil inclination serves a divine purpose.

ותקיף חיליה מהמתגבר על יצרו כי בזה יהיה מרכבה אל כח הקדושה בבחינתה המשברת מלתעות עול בדאמרי׳ בגמ׳ דברכות פ״ב לעולם יהיה אדם ערום ביראה. ופרש״י להערים בכל מיני ערמה ליראת בוראו מענה רך ומשיב חמה וכו׳ כדי שיהיה אהוב למעלה ונחמד למטה וראוי לדעת כי לא יתעצם הדבר להיותו במדרגה העליונה אם לא ירד במדרגות התחתונות להתלבן ולהצטרף שם. כי בזה משנים התחתונים ישליך טרף.[i] וכמה פנות מהתורה נכללים בדרוש זה. ואשרי היורד למצולות ים בשלום ויוצא משם בשלום כאברהם שירד למצרים ויצא משם בתוספות השפעות מנשמות קדושות הנרמזים בפסוק ואברם כבד מאד במקנה וגו׳ וגם ללוט ההולך את אברם זכה שבאו מזרעו נשמות רות ונעמה דוגמתו יצחק עצם מאד בארץ פלשתים יעקב הוציא מבית לבן כמה מרגלאן שפירן דאינון שפירתא דכל גינתא דעדן וכבש שור וחמור צאן ועבד ושפחה ושם מרוחו עליהם. ועל האמת גנב לבו של לבן שרומז לתוכיות הקדושה שהביא משם. וסוד המ״ב מסעות שעשו

in Tractate Berakhot chapter 2: "A person should always be cunning in fear [of Heaven]." Rashi explains: to employ every kind of cunning in fearing his Creator—with a gentle response, turning away wrath, etc.—so that he may be beloved above and pleasing below.

It is worth knowing that nothing can attain the highest level without first descending to lower levels to be whitened and refined there.[A] For through this, "he casts prey from the lower realms." Many aspects of Torah are included in this discourse. Fortunate is one who descends into the depths of the sea in peace and emerges in peace,[1] like Abraham who went down to Egypt and came out with additional influences from holy souls, as alluded to in the verse "And Abram was very rich in livestock, etc." Even Lot, who accompanied Abram, merited that from his descendants came the souls of Ruth and Naamah.

Similarly, Isaac prospered greatly in the land of the Philistines. Jacob brought out from Laban's house many beautiful pearls that are the beauty of the entire Garden of Eden.[B] He subdued ox and donkey, sheep, manservant, and maidservant, and placed his spirit upon them. In truth, he stole Laban's heart, symbolizing the inner essence of holiness that he brought from there.

The secret of the forty-two journeys that Israel made in the great and terrible wilderness, a place dominated by serpent, fiery serpent, scorpion, and thirst[2]—which will be explained later—was to travel and conquer from shell to shell, breaking and crushing them. Therefore, they were all enumerated in the Torah.

[A] Or: "to be purified and refined there" — While 'whitened' is a literal translation of 'להתלבן', in kabbalistic contexts this often refers to spiritual purification. The alternate translation conveys the spiritual concept more clearly to modern readers.

[B] Or: "precious pearls that are the most beautiful in all the Garden of Eden" — This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar could be translated with slightly different emphasis, highlighting the superlative nature of these 'pearls' (symbolic of spiritual entities or insights).

[1] This metaphor of spiritual descent for the purpose of ascent (yerida tzorech aliya) is a central kabbalistic concept. It suggests that engaging with lower realms, when done properly, can yield spiritual benefits and transformation.

[2] These four elements from Deuteronomy 8:15 are interpreted in kabbalistic literature as representing four types of negative spiritual forces (kelipot) that must be confronted and transformed in the spiritual journey.

[i] This difficult phrase appears to be alluding to Job 39:3, but repurposed in a kabbalistic context to suggest that through descending to lower realms, one can extract spiritual 'prey' or elevate divine sparks.

ישראל במדבר[i] הגדול והנורא
מקום שליטת נחש שרף ועקרב
וצמאון[ii] אשר יתבארו לפנינו
היה כדי ליסע ולכבוש מקליפה
לקליפה לשברם ולכתותם. על
כן נמנו כלם בתורה: [iii]

פרק ב׳

Chapter 2

במה עמקו מאד מחשבות של
יוצר בראשית ברוך הוא להמציא
קליפה זו במציאות לתכלית
שבארנו וגם צורך מציאותה
להשכיר ולהעניש בעין גיהנם
ששכר עבירה עבירה. כי אין
העונש בגיהנם על הנקמה ח״ו
רק ליתום חלאת הנפש החוטאת
שם למען תסולה בכתם אופיר

How profoundly deep are the thoughts of the Creator, blessed be He, who brought forth this husk into existence for the purpose we have explained, and also for its necessary function to reward and punish, similar to Gehenna, where "the reward of sin is sin."[1] For the punishment in Gehenna is not for vengeance, God forbid, but only to purify the filth of the sinning soul so that it may be refined like fine gold in the Garden of Delights.[A] This husk 5R

[A] Or: "so that it may be treasured like Ophir gold in the Garden of Delights" — This alternate translation preserves the specific reference to 'Ophir gold' (a biblical term for the finest gold) rather than generalizing to 'fine gold,' and translates 'תסולה' as 'treasured' rather than 'refined,' which could better capture the nuance of value being placed on the soul after purification.

[1] This is a reference to Pirkei Avot 4:2, which states that the reward of a mitzvah (commandment) is a mitzvah and the consequence of a sin is a sin, suggesting that actions create their own spiritual momentum and consequences.

[i] The forty-two journeys of Israel in the wilderness (Numbers 33) have special significance in kabbalah. The number 42 corresponds to a divine name (the 42-letter Name), and these journeys are often interpreted as stages in spiritual development or as a process for rectifying aspects of reality.
[ii] This phrase from Deuteronomy 8:15 describing the wilderness is interpreted in kabbalah as referring to four types of negative spiritual forces (kelipot) that must be overcome in the spiritual journey.
[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parshat Tzav — The author is using this Zoharic reference to develop a theodicy—explaining that even evil has a constructive purpose in the divine plan, just as tree bark (seemingly extraneous) actually protects and beautifies the tree. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Terumah — This reference supports the author's theological claim that even the evil inclination serves a divine purpose and can ultimately be elevated when it is properly overcome and transformed. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Bava Metzia — This reference supports the author's discussion of the afterlife and how righteous souls maintain their individuality while contributing to the collective spiritual reality of the Garden of Eden. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Shabbat — This complements the previous Talmudic reference, reinforcing the author's point about individual spiritual accomplishment while also emphasizing the collective enrichment of the Garden of Eden when a righteous person enters it. | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot — This reference supports the author's discussion of how overcoming the evil inclination requires strategic spiritual efforts, not just brute force resistance, illustrating the sophisticated approach to spiritual self-development in rabbinic thought. | Cf. Biblical narrative of Abraham in Egypt — The author is using Abraham's biblical journey as a kabbalistic metaphor for the mystical principle of 'descent for the sake of ascent' (yerida tzorech aliya), suggesting that engaging with the material world (symbolized by Egypt) can yield spiritual benefits when done properly. | Cf. Biblical forty-two journeys of Israel in the wilderness — The author is offering a kabbalistic interpretation of the biblical narrative, suggesting that the historical journey described in Numbers had a deeper spiritual purpose of confronting and transforming spiritual obstacles (kelipot/shells). | Cf. Babylonian Talmud, Menachot — This reference reinforces the author's point about spiritual development being a gradual process that reaches its culmination only at the end, like an olive that ripens fully only in its final stage.

בגן עדנות. קליפה זו היא
הנבראת ביום השני מצד הגבורה
לבד והיא הנמשלת במשל הזונה
בנזכר.[i] ועל בחינה זו יתבאר
למשכיל טעם אכילת קרבן פסח
המקריבים אותו לטהרה וסוד
בחינה הפנימית שממנה נבראו
השרים שבבחינתם הפנימית
ההיא הם טהורים ונקיים ושבעים
פרי החג יוביחו.[ii] וכן שער
של תפלין ושרפת פרה אדומה
ואין כאן מקומו של דרוש זה
כי יתרחב מאד ועת לכל חפץ
בלי נדר אם יגזור השם. אמנם
מלבד החלק הזה הנתן בו
ברצון. נתוסף באדם יצה"ר
חלק שני כ"י בלי רצונו והוא
סוד הקליפה שנתוספה על ידי
מיעוט הירח. שאז ביום רביעי
נתחזקה הקליפה יותר ויותר
למאד מאד. ולכן חלק יצה"ר
מאותו הצד חזק מאד עד שמטעם
זה נתקללה הארץ ופירשו
בתקונים ארץ זה באימא תתאה
שהיא גרמה צד חוזק יצה"ר
באדם בלי רצון קונו וזהו עולם
שלא ברצונו. ובהיות הלבנה
במלואה והקליפה נטהרת וכח
המארת חסרה ומתבטלת אז
הוא עלמא די ברא כרעותיה.
עוד העמיק הרחיב מדורת האש
החצוני ונתחזק היצה"ר באדם
מעת חטא אדם הראשון. כי
בתחלה היה לו חלק יוכל שאת
מחומריות ועוביות יצה"ר והוא
לקח והגביר על עצמו חלק
גדול כמה פעמים עד כי הוא

was created on the second day solely from the side of Gevurah[1] (Strength/Judgment), and it is metaphorically represented by the harlot mentioned previously. Based on this understanding, the wise will comprehend the reason for eating the Passover sacrifice, which is offered for purification, and the mystery of the inner aspect from which the celestial princes were created, who in their inner essence are pure and clean—as the seventy bulls of the Festival prove. The same applies to the hair used in tefillin and the burning of the red heifer, though this is not the place to expand on this teaching, as it would become too extensive, and there is a time for every purpose, God willing.

However, beyond this portion given willingly, a second part of the evil inclination was added to humans against His will. This is the mystery of the husk that was added through the diminishment of the moon. On the fourth day, this husk was greatly strengthened and intensified. Therefore, the evil inclination from that aspect became so powerful that for this reason the earth was cursed. The Tikkunim explain that "earth" here refers to the lower Mother (Imma Tata'ah/Malkhut), which caused the strengthening of the evil inclination in humans against the will of their Creator—and this is a world not according to His will. But when the moon is full and the husk is purified, and the power of the curse is diminished and nullified, then it becomes a world created according to His will.

The fiery dwelling of the external forces was further deepened and expanded, and the evil inclination in humans was strengthened from the time of Adam's sin. Initially, he had a portion of the evil inclination's materiality and coarseness that he could bear, but he took upon himself and magnified a much greater portion many times over,

[1] In Kabbalistic thought, Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) is the divine attribute associated with limitation, discipline, and severity. The author suggests that negative spiritual forces originated from this attribute on the second day of creation, before it was balanced with Chesed (Loving-kindness).

[i] This refers to a parable in the Zohar where a king sends a harlot to test his son's virtue. The harlot represents the evil inclination, which though seemingly negative, serves the king's purpose when it is resisted and overcome.

[ii] This refers to the seventy sacrificial bulls offered during Sukkot (the Festival of Booths), which decrease in number each day. In rabbinic tradition, these seventy bulls correspond to the seventy nations of the world, suggesting that even the celestial princes of other nations have an inner purity.

דנורא ואנן דבשרא.[i] ולכן הבא
ליטהר בעי סיועא מפני היצה״ר
כדאמרי׳ בגמרא מנחות בצורת
ה״א שדומה לאכסדרא. ובזה
נבין אמרם ז״ל אדם הראשון
מושך כו׳ וזה נתהוה ביום ששי
שעת החטא כי היה ראוי לאדם
הראשון להתפלל מנחה גדולה
בגודל ויחוד עליון וחטאו גרם
שהתפלל מנחה קטנה בעניות
ומיעוט ודרשו בשבת פרק כ״ב
וביבמות פרק י״ב ובמס׳ ע״ג
פ״ב על פסוק הנחש השיאני לשון
נשואין שהטיל בחוה זוהמא.
וכתבו התוספות בסנהדרין פ״ג
כי הנחש לא נצטוה שלא להסית
ולא נענש אלא לפי שבאה תקלה
על ידה אבל שאר המסיתין
שנצטוו שלא להסית לא שייך
ביה למימר דברי הרב ודברי
התלמיד וכו׳ באופן כי גברה
הקליפות ונתקללו אדם וחוה
ונחש לכן הוצרך צירוף בכור
הברזל ארבע מאות שנה נגד ד׳
מאות שקל בסף עליונים צנורות
הנשמות שסתמו בחטאם ועד
סוף הזמן ההוא הוצרכו להצרף
בכור הברזל במצרים כי היו
מכח החצוניות הרבה ואחר זמן
זה יצאו נשמות טהורות וזהו
ואחרי כן יצאו ברכוש גדול
ויהיה רכוש מלשון שרי הרכש.

until "he is of fire and we are of flesh." Therefore, one who comes to purify himself needs assistance because of the evil inclination, as stated in the Talmud Menachot regarding the shape of the letter Hei, which resembles a portico.[A] Through this we understand our Sages' statement that "Adam drew down [the foreskin],"[B] which occurred on the sixth day at the time of the sin, for Adam should have prayed the "great Mincha" with greatness and supreme unification,[1] but his sin caused him to pray the "small Mincha" in poverty and diminishment.

The Sages expounded in Shabbat chapter 22, Yevamot chapter 12, and Avodah Zarah chapter 2 on the verse "The serpent deceived me" (hishi'ani), interpreting it as related to marriage (nisu'in), meaning that the serpent injected impurity into Eve. Tosafot wrote in Sanhedrin chapter 3 that the serpent was not commanded not to entice and was only punished because harm came through it, but regarding other enticers who were commanded not to entice, the principle "when faced with the words of the master and the words of the student..." does not apply. Thus, the husks grew stronger, and Adam, Eve, and the serpent were cursed. Therefore, purification in the iron furnace was required for four hundred years, corresponding to the four hundred shekels of silver representing the supernal channels of souls that were blocked by their sin. Until the end of that period, they needed to be refined in the iron furnace in Egypt, as they were greatly affected by external forces. After this time, purified souls emerged—this is the meaning of "afterward they

[A] Or: "Therefore, one who seeks purification requires divine assistance against the evil inclination, as explained in the Talmud Menachot regarding the letter Hei's shape resembling a portico with an opening at the bottom through which one might fall" — This alternate translation makes more explicit the talmudic reference about the letter Hei's shape, which serves as a metaphor for how someone seeking spiritual purification needs divine assistance to avoid falling through the 'opening' that represents vulnerability to the evil inclination.

[B] Or: "Adam drew down his foreskin" — This alternate translation explicitly states what was being drawn down, referring to a rabbinic teaching that Adam pulled his foreskin to extend it, symbolizing his movement away from the covenant with God. The abbreviated expression 'וכו" (etc.) in the original text assumes familiarity with this teaching.

[1] This refers to kabbalistic prayer intentions. The 'great Mincha' likely refers to the afternoon prayer with proper mystical intentions (kavvanot) that would have created divine unifications in upper realms. Adam's sin reduced this to a 'small Mincha,' symbolizing diminished spiritual capacity.

[i] This is an Aramaic expression meaning 'he is of fire and we are of flesh,' indicating the immense power of the evil inclination compared to human frailty. It appears in Talmudic literature to express the difficulty of spiritual struggle.

ברם נשמת יעקב בחיר האבות
והשבטים עד תשלום שבעים נפש
יש לדרוש בהם מה טיבם אז
והשתא לאו להכי אתינא. ויציאת
מצרים היתה מצד הבינה הנוגפת
ומבערת החצונים ומשם יצאו
דור דעה המושפעים מבינה.
ומשה רבינו ע״ה בראשם פני
חמה. אמנם כיבוש הארץ היתה
מצד מלכות על ידי יהושע פני
לבנה. ומלכות אינה חפצה
רק להכניע החצונים מפני
שהם צורך העולם. ולכן מהם
עזבו ישראל בכוונה עליונה
להוכיחם. כי גם הם לא תוהו
נבראו בדכתיב והשיבו את
האבן על פי הבאר למקומה.
והנה הקליפה הרביעית שהיא
המזיקים שנבראו בששי היא
מעין הקליפה שנבראת ביום
שני דהיינו גיהנם אמנם נתחזקה
הרבה במה שקדם אליה מנין
יום רביעי דהיינו המיעוט וחטא
אדם ביום ששי. ופסיקת הזוהמת
שהיתה בסיני היה תקון מה שמשך
כו׳. וחלק שני שהוא מיעוט
הירח היה תלוי עד שיכנסו
לארץ ושם תהיה הלבנה במלואה
כמו שהיתה בזמן שלמה ולא היה
ראוי להשאר אליהם אלא חלק
יצה״ר שאינו זוהמא מהנחש.
אבל הוא סוד הזונה שיש לה
שכר לפעולתה. כי זוהמת הנחש
אין לו שכר לפעולתו כלל אבל
יצר הרע יכיל למהוי יצר טוב.
והיינו חלק הניתן בו ברצון קונו
והיה להם לישראל אחר שיעמדו
זמן מה בארץ לזכות אל זמן
התחיה שהוא זמן תקון יצר הרע
מכל וכל. והטעם כי בקימת
הצדיקים מעפרם שהגבירו חלק

shall come out with great wealth," where "wealth" (rechush) is related to "officers of the chariots" (sarei harechesh).[1] 80R

Regarding the soul of Jacob, the chosen one of the Patriarchs, and the tribes, up to the completion of seventy souls, one could investigate their nature at that time, but that is not our present purpose. The 85R exodus from Egypt occurred through Binah (Understanding), which strikes and eliminates the external forces, and from there emerged the Generation of Knowledge, influenced by Binah. Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, was at their head with "the 90R face of the sun." However, the conquest of the land came from the aspect of Malkhut (Kingdom) through Jo[2]shua, "the face of the moon." Malkhut desires only to subdue the external forces because they are necessary for the world. Therefore, some of them 95R were deliberately left by Israel to prove them, for even they were not created for chaos, as it is written, "And they returned the stone to the mouth of the well in its place."

The fourth husk, which is the harmful entities 100R created on the sixth day, is similar to the husk created on the second day, namely Gehenna, but it was greatly strengthened by what preceded it—the count of the fourth day, meaning the diminishment, and Adam's sin on the sixth day. The cutting off of the 105R impurity that occurred at Sinai was a correction of what he "drew down." The second part, which is the diminishment of the moon, was suspended until they entered the land, where the moon would be full as it was in Solomon's time. It was appropriate that only 110R the portion of the evil inclination that is not the serpent's impurity should remain with them. Rather, it is the mystery of the harlot who receives reward for her work. For the serpent's impurity receives no reward for its work at all, but the evil inclination has 115R the potential to become the good inclination. This is the portion given with the Creator's will, and it was meant for Israel, after they had been in the land for some time, to merit the time of resurrection, which

[1] The author makes a creative etymological connection between the biblical term for wealth (רכוש/rechush) and the term for chariot officers (שרי הרכש/sarei harechesh), suggesting that the spiritual 'wealth' gained from Egypt was actually purified souls that would serve as spiritual vehicles.

[2] This uses kabbalistic symbolism where the sun represents Tiferet (associated with Moses and direct revelation from Binah) while the moon represents Malkhut (associated with Joshua and the more limited revelation appropriate for life in the physical world).

היצר טוב על יצר הרע[i] בזה
כבר נתקן ונעשה ימין אם כן שוב
לא ישוב לכסלה. ובנס התחיה
יובללו כל הנסים והוא תכלית
תקון החומרים והצורות ויש
לדרוש בתחיה מהותה ואיכותה
וכמותה וסגולתה וזמנה ומקומה
והדרוש רחב במקומו ובה
יתחברו ארבע יסודות רוחניות
של נשמה שהם צלם נפש רוח
נשמה וזהו מארבע רוחות בוא
הרוח וכמו שטל חרמון שהוא
שפע יהו מלא באלפין שעולה
ט״ל[ii] בן השמן של מעלה ירד
על הר המשחה להעיר הנפש
לתחיה ולזה נקרא הר המשחה
והר הזתים מפני מרירות המיתה
שקבלו הגופים. וחלק הנתוסף
בעון הנחש והמיעוט כבר נתקן
עם המיתה והגאולה. אם כן שוב
אינן חוזרים לעפרם. וכבר ידעת
כי המיתה היא מתיחת הדין לא
לבד על הנפטר גם על המשפחה
ועל הפגם העשוי במשפחה לזה
תקנו שיקרעו קרוביו ומיודעיו
עליו וכפי גודל הפגם כן תהיה
הקריעה ולבן באביו ואמו קורע
כל בגדיו עד שיגלה לבו ובשאר
מתים קורע העליון לבד. וכן
הרבה חלוקים באבילות בין
אביו ואמו לשאר מתים והכל נתן
לידרש כפי דרך זה:[iii]

is the time of complete rectification of the evil inclination. The reason is that when the righteous rise from their dust—those who strengthened the good inclination over the evil inclination—it has already been rectified and made "right," so it will not return to folly. The miracle of resurrection will include all miracles and is the ultimate rectification of the material and forms.

One could expound on resurrection: its essence, quality, quantity, virtue, time, and place—this is a broad subject in its own context. In resurrection, the four spiritual elements of the soul will unite, which are the divine image (tzelem), vital soul (nefesh), spirit (ruach), and higher soul (neshamah), and this is the meaning of "from the four winds, come, O spirit." Just as the dew of Hermon, which is the divine flow of the name YHV filled with the letter alef (which equals 39 in gematria), so will the supernal oil descend upon the Mount of Anointing to awaken the soul to resurrection. For this reason, it is called the Mount of Anointing (Har HaMishchah) and the Mount of Olives (Har HaZeitim) because of the bitterness of death experienced by the bodies.

The portion added due to the serpent's sin and the diminishment has already been rectified through death and redemption. Therefore, they will not return to dust again. You already know that death is an extension of judgment not only upon the deceased but also upon the family and the blemish created within the family. For this reason, they instituted that relatives and acquaintances should tear their garments for him, and according to the magnitude

[i]The author presents a theology where the righteous, through their spiritual struggles in life, transform the evil inclination itself into something positive. At resurrection, this transformation becomes permanent, representing the ultimate cosmic rectification.

[ii]This involves complex kabbalistic letter-mysticism: the divine name YHV (יהו) with the letter alef (א) inserted between each letter creates a numerical value of 39 (י=10, ה=5, ו=6, and three alephs at 1 each). This equals the numerical value of טל (tet=9, lamed=30), the Hebrew word for 'dew,' which rabbinic tradition associates with resurrection.

[iii]Cf. Zohar — The author draws on the Zoharic concept that negative spiritual forces were created on the second day as a necessary aspect of Creation, specifically from the divine attribute of Gevurah (severity/judgment) | Cf. Talmud — The author uses this talmudic reference to explain how the soul needs divine assistance for purification, as the letter Hei's design shows how one might fall through the bottom opening (representing spiritual vulnerability) without support | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author incorporates the kabbalistic teaching that the diminishment of the moon represents a cosmic imbalance affecting the lower divine feminine aspect (Malkhut), which strengthened negative forces in creation | Cf. Genesis — The author uses this biblical reference metaphorically to explain that some external forces were deliberately left in the world because they serve a necessary purpose in creation, just as the stone was returned to cover the well | Cf. Midrash — The author integrates the midrashic concept of resurrection dew with kabbalistic letter-mysticism, connecting it to divine names and the numerical value of טל (dew) equaling 39,

of the blemish, so will be the tearing. Therefore, for one's father and mother, one tears all garments until exposing the heart, but for other deceased, one tears only the upper garment. Similarly, there are many distinctions in mourning between parents and other deceased, and all of this can be interpreted according to this approach. 155R

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

טל אורות עליונים[i] שהכין יוצר בראשית לבני התחיה היה מזומן להחיות הדורות שקדמו לדור שיצאו ממצרים שכבר מתו מאז כאבות העולם ושאר מתים ח״ל וא״י. אמנם דור דעה היה ראוי להיות חירות ממ״ה[ii] וחירות משעבוד וזה על ידי קיום המצות בארץ זמן מה ידוע ליוצר אמנם לא נמשכה כוונה זו על הדרך הנזכר יען כי קלקלו בעגל בעון חטא אדה״ר ממש שמשך עליו כו׳[iii] אף הם משכו עליהם כו׳ ונשאר העולם שומם כשהיה. ועכ״ז היה אפשר להם התקון השני. על ידי הכניסה לארץ. וגם לזה לא זכו וקלקלו לעצמם כדפירשו בההוא עובדא דינוקא בפ׳ ופגריכם אתם יפלו במדבר הזה. ובזה נדע כי בגאולה יתוקן מה שנתוסף מצד מיעוט הירח. ויהיה אור הלבנה כאור החמה וישארו האנשים קרובים לעבודת קונם. ועוד נהיה פנויים לענייני העולם הגשמי לרוב העידון והזהב הכסף והמזון עד שיתבטל

The supernal dew of lights that the Creator of the Beginning prepared for those destined for resurrection was ready to revive the generations that preceded those who left Egypt, who had already died long before, such as the Patriarchs and other deceased, both outside the Land of Israel and within it. However, the Generation of Knowledge[1] (those who left Egypt) was worthy of freedom from the Angel of Death and freedom from servitude through fulfilling the commandments in the Land for a specific time known to the Creator. But this purpose did not proceed as planned because they corrupted themselves with the Golden Calf, committing exactly the same sin as Adam, who "drew upon himself, etc."—likewise, they "drew upon themselves, etc.," and the world remained desolate as it was before. 5R 10R 15R

Nevertheless, a second rectification was possible for them through entering the Land. Yet they did not merit even this and corrupted themselves, as explained in the story of the child in the section "And your carcasses shall fall in this wilderness." From this we understand that in the final redemption, what was added due to the diminishment of the moon[2] will be rectified. The light of the moon will become like the light of the sun, and people will remain close to the service of their Creator. We will also be free from 20R 25R

[1] This term (דור דעה) specifically refers to the Israelites who left Egypt and received the Torah at Mount Sinai, so named because they directly experienced divine revelation.

[2] This refers to a midrashic concept that the moon was originally equal to the sun in size and brightness but was diminished after complaining to God. In kabbalistic thought, this represents cosmic imbalance that will be rectified in the messianic era.

which represents divine revitalizing energy

[i] This "dew of supernal lights" is a kabbalistic concept referring to divine effluence that will resurrect the dead. It appears in Isaiah 26:19: "For Your dew is a dew of lights."

[ii] The acronym מ״ה likely refers to מלאך המות (Malakh HaMavet), the Angel of Death. The Generation of Knowledge could have achieved immortality had they not sinned with the Golden Calf.

[iii] The abbreviation כו׳ (etc.) refers to a well-known teaching that Adam "drew upon himself the foreskin/serpent" through his sin. This is a euphemistic reference to the introduction of sexual desire and death into human existence.

חלק גדול מהחמדה והצורך אל
הדברים הגשמיים. והמיתה היא
תקון אל מה שמשך בו׳ ומכ״ש
כי יתוקן חלק שנתן הבורא בהם
במה שהם צדיקים והגבירו הימין
על שמאל ויצה״ר נעשה טוב.
אמנם החיים שלא מתו אם יהיה
צורך המיתה להם לפחות שעה
אחת לתקון חלק מה שמשכו
בערלה זה מקום ספק. ואחר
התחיה עדיין ישארו מבעלי
חיים הדברים הטמאים מפני
שהם חלק צד הרע הנכנע אל
הטוב ולכן אז יכנעו אל הימניית
כאומרו לא ירעו ולא ישחיתו
וגר זאב עם כבש וכן יהיו אז
כל אותם העתידים לחוג את
חג הסכות בסוד שבעים פרי
החג ואולם אחר זמן התחיה
הוא דבר לא נודע מה יהיה
אפילו לצדיקים בג״ע בדפי׳
בזהר רות. וארבע בחינות
יצה״ר שהזכרנו הם נזכרים
ונרמזים במזמור קי״ח מלבד מה
שדרשנו בו במאמר ג׳ פרק כ׳
אחר שהזכיר ד׳ פעמים כל״ח
לעורר כח החסדים גדולים
מאריך שהוא כתר האצילות
ואח״כ השפיע מהחכמה שהיא
אימא שבה שם י״ה בפ׳ מן המצר
קראתי יה. ואח״כ המשיך מאימא
דלא דחילת מנין הטורף והיא
שוברת כח החצונים וזה בפסוק
ה׳ לי לא אירא מה יעשה לי
אדם. שרומז לאדם בליעל
מרכבת ס״מ ולילית. ומשם
השפיע ויחד כל ו׳ קצוות של
ז״א בפסוק ה׳ לי בעוזרי ואני
אראה בשונאי. ובפסוק טוב
לחסות בה׳ יחד כל האצילות עם
נוקביה דזעיר ובפסוק מלאחריו
הזכיר דרגין דכורסייא שהם
עלמות שיר והיכלות שבע

material concerns due to the abundance of refinement, gold, silver, and food, until a large portion of desire and need for physical things will be nullified.

Death is a rectification for what Adam "drew upon himself," and all the more so will the portion that the Creator placed in the righteous be rectified when they strengthen the right (mercy) over the left (judgment), and the evil inclination becomes good. However, for those who remain alive, whether they will need to experience death, even for just one hour, to rectify the portion they "drew through the foreskin"—this remains doubtful. 30R 35R

After the resurrection, unclean animals will still exist because they represent the aspect of evil that is subjugated to good. Therefore, they will submit to the right side, as it is said, "They shall not hurt nor destroy," and "The wolf shall dwell with the lamb." So shall it be with all those destined to celebrate the Festival of Sukkot, in the mystery of the seventy bulls of the festival.[1] But what will happen after the time of resurrection is unknown, even for the righteous in the Garden of Eden, as explained in the Zohar on Ruth. 40R 45R

The four aspects of the evil inclination that we mentioned are referenced and alluded to in Psalm 118, beyond what we expounded on in Discourse 3, Chapter 20. After mentioning "His kindness endures forever" four times to awaken the power of great mercies from Arich, which is Keter of Emanation,[2] the psalmist then draws from Wisdom, which is Imma (Mother), in which resides the divine name Yah, in the verse "From distress I called upon Yah." He then draws from Imma, who does not fear the tearing predator[3] and breaks the power of the external forces, as in the verse "The LORD is for me, I shall not fear; what can man do to me?"—referring to the wicked man who is the vehicle of Samael and Lilith. 50R 55R 60R

From there, he unified all six extremities of Zeir Anpin in the verse "The LORD is for me among my helpers; therefore I will look upon those who hate me." In the verse "It is better to take refuge in the LORD," he unified all of Emanation with the female aspect of Zeir, and in the following verse, he 65R

[1] This refers to the total number of bull sacrifices offered during the seven days of Sukkot, which traditionally were understood to correspond to the seventy nations of the world.

[2] In Kabbalah, Keter (Crown) is the highest of the ten sefirot (divine emanations), and is associated with God's will and the aspect called Arich Anpin (Long-Faced One).

[3] In kabbalistic symbolism, Imma (Mother) corresponds to the sefirah of Binah (Understanding) which has the power to overcome and neutralize negative spiritual forces.

דיצירה ואמר כי אין לבטוח בהם הנקרא נדיבים להיות בה׳ מבטחנו ואליו ולא למדותיו וכ״ש לנבראיו ומלאכיו. בהגיעו לעולם העשייה ששם סביבו רשעים יתהלכון נגד ארבע בחינות יצה״ר שהזכרנו שהם ארבע מסכים שהזכיר יחזקאל רוח סערה. ענן גדול. ואש מתלקחת. ונגה. אמר נגד הג׳ ראשונות ממטה למעלה ג׳ פעמים בשם ה׳ כי אמילם. כי מלכותו בכל משלה לאכנעא לון כנזכר למעלה במאמר ג׳ פרק הנ״ל. ברם נוגה אינה קליפה טמאה אלא שאין השפע מתגלה בה כדי שלא יהנו ממנו החצונים השוכנים אצלה. ושמות ארבע קליפות אלו הם נחש שרף ועקרב וצמאון כנזכר. וזוהי קליפת נגה הצמאה לקדושה הנמנעת ממנה מחמת שכנותה אצל שלש האחרים הטמאים וזהו אוי לרשע ואוי לשכנו[i] ובהדי הוצא לקי כרבא.[ii] לכן בקליפה הרביעית הזאת לא נאמר בה כי אמילם כראשונים רק וה׳ עזרני. ומצינו בגמ׳ שלשה מיני חמורים. בשבת פרק ט״ו חמורו של רבי חנינא בן דוסא ושל רבי פנחס בן יאיר בפרק הכל שוחטין ובתענית פ״ג חמורו של ר׳ יוסי דמן יוקרת. ואולי כוונת החסידים אלו היה לעשות מצע תחתיהם ולכבוש ג׳ קליפות קשות שאינם נכללים בקדושה. והצליחו במעשיהם כי חזרו להיות עושים רצונם על דרך שאמרו בסנהדרין פ״ז על נחש. חבל על שמש גדול שאבד מן העולם כו׳ וחמורו של אברהם אבינו ע״ה ושל ר״מ ושל משיח צדקנו אולי יהיו מקובלים לשלש מדרגות

mentioned the levels of the Throne, which are the maidens of song and the seven palaces of Formation. He said not to trust in these, called "nobles," but to place our trust in the LORD Himself, not in His attributes, and certainly not in His creations and angels. 70R 75R

When reaching the World of Action, where "the wicked walk around," corresponding to the four aspects of the evil inclination we mentioned—which are the four screens that Ezekiel mentioned: stormy wind, great cloud, flashing fire, and brightness—he said against the first three, from bottom to top, "In the name of the LORD I will surely cut them off" three times, for His kingdom rules over all, to subdue them, as mentioned above in Discourse 3 in the aforementioned chapter. However, nogah (brightness) is not an impure shell, but rather the divine flow is not revealed in it so that the external forces dwelling near it should not benefit. The names of these four shells are serpent, fiery serpent, scorpion, and thirst, as mentioned. This nogah shell thirsts for holiness but is prevented from receiving it due to its proximity to the other three impure shells. This is the meaning of "Woe to the wicked and woe to his neighbor," and "With the thorns, the cabbage is also smitten." Therefore, regarding this fourth shell, it does not say "I will cut them off" as with the first three, but rather "The LORD helped me." 80R 85R 90R 95R

We find in the Talmud three types of donkeys: in Shabbat Chapter 15, the donkey of Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa; in the chapter "All May Slaughter" and in Ta'anit Chapter 3, the donkey of Rabbi Pinchas ben Yair; and the donkey of Rabbi Yose of Yokeret. Perhaps the intention of these pious ones was to create a foundation beneath themselves and to conquer the three severe shells that cannot be included in holiness. They succeeded in their deeds, for these shells returned to doing their will, as they said in Sanhedrin Chapter 7 regarding the serpent: "It is a pity that a great servant was lost from the world, etc." And the donkey of our father Abraham, peace be upon him, and of Rabbi Meir, and of our righteous Messiah—perhaps they correspond to three levels that are close 100R 105R 110R

[i] This is a rabbinic saying from the Talmud (Sukkah 56b): "Woe to the wicked and woe to his neighbor." It expresses that proximity to evil can contaminate even that which is not inherently evil.

[ii] This Aramaic expression from the Talmud (Bava Kamma 92a) means "along with the thorns, the cabbage is also smitten"—a metaphor for collateral damage.

הקרובים אל הקדושה זה יותר מזה שהם בקליפת נגה. ובשבת
115 פ׳ ר׳ עקיבא ובילמדנו פ׳ יתרו דרשו שם הרבה דברים משולשים שנוכל לדרוש הרבה מהם כדרך זה:[i]

to holiness, each more so than the other, which are in the shell of nogah. In Shabbat, in the chapter of Rabbi Akiva, and in Yelamdenu, Parashat Yitro, they expounded on many things that come in threes, from which we can derive many teachings in this manner. 115R

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

כוונת האדם בכל מעשה תוקפו בעוה״ז תהיה להחליש כח הדין ולהגביר ימין ה׳[ii] שתהיה רוממה ותעשה חיל ולעולם ישריש
5 נפשו ונפשות החיים ההולכים אחר עצתו במקום עליון דלא שלטת תמן מותא שהוא עלמא דדכורא[iii] סוד ז״א בסוד שימני כחותם[iv] שהוא המציאות אשר
10 למלכות עם ת״ת ממש. כי יש כח וספוק ביד צדיק אחד לזכות הרבה אחרים עמו כפי מחצב נשמתו על דרך שנאמר באברהם וארבה אותך במאד
15 מאד. שאמרו כי יפה כחה

A person's intention in all their powerful actions in this world should be to weaken the power of judgment and strengthen God's right hand, that it may be exalted and perform mightily. One should always root one's soul and the souls of those living who follow one's counsel in the supernal place where death has no do[1]minion—the masculine realm, the secret of Zeir Anpin,[2] in the mystery of "Set me as a seal," which is the reality that belongs to Malkhut with Tiferet itself. For a single righteous person has the power and capacity to bring merit to many others along with themself, according to the source of their soul, as it was said of Abraham: "I will multiply you exceedingly." For they said that the soul of Abraham had the beautiful power to gather all the songs and 5R 10R 15R

[1] This passage suggests the kabbalistic concept that human souls can be spiritually elevated to transcend the realm of mortality through proper spiritual practice and intention.

[2] I've maintained the technical kabbalistic terminology here, as Zeir Anpin (literally 'Small Face' or 'Lesser Countenance') is a specific divine configuration in Kabbalah that doesn't have a simple English equivalent.

[i] Cf. Psalm 118 — The author interprets Psalm 118 through a kabbalistic lens, seeing the psalm as describing the flow of divine energy through the various sefirot (divine emanations) and their effects on the evil inclination. | Cf. Ezekiel's vision — The author interprets these elements from Ezekiel's vision as corresponding to the four aspects of the evil inclination, connecting biblical imagery to kabbalistic concepts of spiritual impurity. | Cf. Zohar on Ruth — The author references the Zohar's commentary on Ruth as an authoritative source regarding the mysteries of the afterlife and resurrection, showing how kabbalistic texts were used to supplement biblical understanding. | Cf. Talmudic stories about donkeys — The author interprets these Talmudic references mystically, suggesting that these sages' donkeys symbolically represent conquest over impure spiritual forces (kelipot). | Cf. Isaiah 11:6 — The author uses these prophetic verses from Isaiah to describe the messianic era after resurrection, when even impure forces will be transformed and subdued rather than eliminated.

[ii] This phrase reflects a core kabbalistic concept that divine judgment (din) needs to be tempered by divine mercy (often associated with the right side or 'right hand' of God). This is a fundamental theological framework in Jewish mysticism.

[iii] The text refers to 'the supernal place where death has no dominion' as 'the masculine realm' (alma de-dichura), reflecting the kabbalistic concept that masculine divine energy is associated with life and mercy, while feminine energy (alma de-nukba) is associated with judgment and, in some contexts, death.

[iv] Z"A (Zeir Anpin) is a central kabbalistic term referring to the six sefirot from Chesed to Yesod as a unified structure, representing the 'Small Face' of divinity. The phrase 'Set me as a seal' comes from Song of Songs 8:6, interpreted kabbalistically as referring to the union between Zeir Anpin and Malkhut.

של נשמת אברהם לאסוף כל השירים והשבחים הנאמרים מפי כל הנמצאים ולכלול כלם בעולם העשייה והיינו ואברה
20 אותך כעין מה רבו מעשיך ה׳. במאד רומז לעולם היצירה בסוד מטטרו״ן הכולל שיר המלאכים.[i] מאד אדם דבריאה הכולל שיר עולמות כנודע.
25 כי היה אברהם בסוד הנפש כולל כל עולם העשייה. וזהו ואברה אותך ובסוד הרוח היה כולל עולם היצירה וזהו במאד. ובסוד הנשמה אדם דבריאה
30 וזהו מאד. ולהגיע למעלות אלו הוצרך ליבחן בעשרה נסיונות ועמד בכולן להודיע כמה חבתו וכחו של אברהם אבינו. בדוגמא זו כל צדיק מיוצאי חלציו
35 יכול להשלים עצמו לכל אחד מארבע פני המרכבה[ii] הכוללים כל מיני אורה והם ארבעה ראשים המאירים לארץ ולדרים בכח ארבע אותיות שמו הגדול
40 המבורך. ובזה הקדושה שאננה ושקטה במעשי ידיהם של צדיקים המוסיפים כח בגבורה של מעלה. על כן ראוי לאדם לפשפש במעשיו ולשוב בתשובה
45 או למשמש פירוש לעת שבא דבר לידו יחשוב הפסד מצוה וכו׳ כדפרש״י בגמ׳ דערובין פ״ק. ויבקש רחמים שיהו הכל מאמצים את כחו כדאמרי׳

praises uttered by all created beings[1] and include them all in the World of Action. This is the meaning of "I will multiply you," similar to "How numerous are Your works, O Lord." "Exceedingly" alludes to the World of Formation through the mystery of Metatron, who encompasses the song of angels. "Exceedingly" also refers to the Adam of Creation who encompasses the song of worlds, as is known. For Abraham, in the mystery of Nefesh, encompassed the entire World of Action[2]—this is "I will multiply you." And in the mystery of Ruach, he encompassed the World of Formation—this is "exceedingly." And in the mystery of Neshamah, the Adam of Creation—this is "exceedingly." To reach these levels, he needed to be tested through ten trials, and he withstood them all, to demonstrate the greatness of Abraham our father's divine love and power. Following this model, every righteous person descended from him can perfect themselves to become one of the four faces of the Divine Chariot,[3] which include all types of light. These are the four luminous heads that shine upon the earth and its inhabitants through the power of the four letters of His great blessed Name. Through this, holiness dwells tranquil and peaceful in the handiwork of the righteous, who add strength to the supernal might. Therefore, it is proper for a person to examine their deeds and repent, or to be attentive—meaning that when something comes to hand, one should consider the loss of a commandment, etc., as Rashi explained in the Talmud, Eruvin, first chapter. And one should pray for mercy that all will strengthen one's power, as we say in Tractate Sanhedrin, chapter 7, where Rashi explained that the ministering angels will assist in seeking mercy,

20R 25R 30R 35R 40R 45R

[1] This portrays Abraham's soul as having a cosmic role in collecting and elevating the praises of all creation, suggesting a view of righteous human souls as active participants in divine cosmic processes.

[2] The text presents a sophisticated spiritual hierarchy where Abraham's soul operated simultaneously at three levels (Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah), each corresponding to a different cosmic world (Asiyah/Action, Yetzirah/Formation, and Beriah/Creation).

[3] The text presents spiritual perfection as becoming integrated into the divine manifestation itself, represented by Ezekiel's vision of the Chariot. This represents a high mystical goal where the righteous person becomes a vehicle for divine presence.

[i] Metatron is an archangel in Jewish tradition considered the highest of the angels. In the kabbalistic system referenced here, Metatron is associated with the World of Formation (Yetzirah) and is seen as conducting the angelic choir.

[ii] The 'four faces of the Divine Chariot' refers to the vision in Ezekiel 1, where the prophet sees a divine chariot with four faces: man, lion, ox, and eagle. In kabbalistic thought, these represent different aspects of divine manifestation and correspond to the four letters of God's name.

במסכתא סנהדרין פ״ז ופרש״י
שמלאכי השרת יסייעוהו לבקש
רחמים ולא יהיו לו צרים
מלמעלה ויעשה שלום במרומיו.
ולפי מה שבארנו במאמר ראשון
על מזלו של אדם שיש לו ברקיע
וכדפירש״י בתענית ובמ״ק
כי מרוז היה מזלו של סיסרא
ולמען לא ינגד למלחמת שמים
נגד סיסרא לכן שמתיה ברק
בד׳ מאה שיפורי. יצא לנו
מזה כמה גדול כח מזלו של
אדם ברקיע וכ״ש מזלן של
צדיקים. גם לזה יכוין בתפלתו
שיאמץ כח מלמעלה. ובמה
יזכה האדם ארחו לקשט ד׳
פני המרכבה. הנה בצד צפון
ממרכבת הרוכב בשמי שמי
קדם שם פני שור.[i] ובהיות
הצדיקים כובשים יצרם בכל
ד׳ בחותיו[ii] אלו הנזכרים והם
גבורים לעמוד בפרץ נגדו בזה
מתקנים צד הצפון וכובשים דיני
הגבורה. קשוט מן המערב ששם
פני נשר[iii] תלוי באותם השומרים
משמרת המערב שלא תחשך אורה
ולא תעריב וזה על ידי עסקם
בדין אמת ומעמידים שורת הדין
על מכונו ונעשים שותף להקב״ה
במעשה בראשית ושונאים ממון
שאינו שלהם. וכן לתקון זה
הפן אותם המסתפקים בעניים
וסובלים יסורים ועונשים גופן
מזבח כפרה כי ה׳ צדיק יבחן

and there will be no adversaries from above, and He will make peace in His heights. According to what we explained in the first discourse about a person's celestial guardian that exists in the firmament,[1] and as Rashi explained in Taanit and Moed Katan that Meroz was Sisera's guardian angel, and so that it would not oppose the war of heaven against Sisera, Barak excommunicated it with four hundred shofar blasts. From this we learn how great is the power of a person's guardian in the firmament, and how much more so the guardians of the righteous. One should also focus on this in prayer—to strengthen power from above. And how can a person make their path worthy to adorn the four faces of the Divine Chariot? Behold, on the northern side of the chariot of the Rider in the ancient heavens is the face of the ox.[2] When the righteous conquer their evil inclination in all four of its aforementioned powers and are mighty to stand in the breach against it, they thereby repair the northern side and subdue the judgments of Gevurah. Adorning the western side, where the face of the eagle is located, depends on those who guard the western watch, ensuring its light does not darken or set. This is accomplished through their engagement with true judgment, establishing justice on its foundation, becoming partners with the Holy One, blessed be He, in the work of creation,[3] and hating money that is not rightfully theirs. Similarly, for the repair of this aspect are those who are satisfied with little, endure suffering and punishments, their body an altar of atonement, for "the Lord tests the righteous," and sufferings of love—when there is judgment above that prevents unification, that judgment flows to the righteous person, and then She [the

[1] This refers to the concept that each person has a spiritual counterpart or guardian angel in the celestial realms. The example of Meroz as Sisera's guardian being excommunicated illustrates the belief that actions in the earthly realm affect these celestial counterparts.

[2] The text maps Ezekiel's vision of the four-faced chariot onto the cardinal directions, with specific correspondences between directions, divine attributes, and spiritual practices. The north is associated with the ox face and divine judgment.

[3] This reflects the rabbinic concept that judges who render true judgments become partners with God in creation, as they maintain the ethical order that sustains the cosmos.

[i] The northern side is traditionally associated with Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) in kabbalistic tradition, and the ox/bull face from Ezekiel's vision is placed there. The north is often connected with the source of harsh judgment that needs to be conquered.

[ii] The evil inclination (yetzer) is described as having four powers, likely corresponding to the four elements or four primary character traits that need to be mastered for spiritual advancement.

[iii] The west is associated with the eagle face from Ezekiel's vision and with sunset/decline, hence the emphasis on guarding against darkness. In kabbalistic thought, the west is often associated with Malkhut, the final divine emanation.

ויסורים של אהבה[i] כשיש דין
למעלה המונע היחוד מושפע
הדין ההוא לצדיק ואז היא
מתייחדת ואומרת הרי הצדיק
הזה פלוני בני סובל יסורין
דין העולם ועומד בצדקו וכל
העולם לא ניזון אלא בשביל
חנינא בני.[ii] ואמרו בגמ׳
דקדושין ס״פ קמא כי הצדיקים
ביסורים הבאים עליהם נמשלים
לאילן שכלו עומד במקום טהרה
ונופו פירוש קצת ממנו נוטה
למקום טומאה וכו׳ ומסיים
כך הקב״ה מביא יסורים על
הצדיקים בעוה״ז בשביל שיירשו
עה״ב שנאמר והיה ראשיתך
מצער ואחריתך ישגה מאד.
ואהרן הכהן שידע שמיתת בניו
היה כמו עקידת יצחק שממש
בידו עקד אברהם איש החסד
ויקח המאכלת לשחוט ולמצות
כח הדין מבנו יצחק בסוד המים
הרו וילדו אפלה.[iii] אף כאן
נדב ואביהוא מתו לעקור הדין
וזהו ואל זועם בכל יום.[iv] וכ״ש
אז שירידת השכינה בתחתונים

Shekhinah] unites and says:[1] "Behold, this righteous
one, my child So-and-so, suffers the judgment of the
world yet stands firm in righteousness, and the en-
tire world is sustained only for the sake of Hanina
my son."[2] And they said in Tractate Kiddushin, at
the end of the first chapter, that the righteous with
the sufferings that come upon them are compared
to a tree that stands entirely in a place of purity
while its branches—meaning part of it—extend to-
ward a[3] place of impurity, etc. It concludes: "Thus
the Holy One, blessed be He, brings suffering upon
the righteous in this world so that they may inherit
the World to Come, as it says, 'Though your be-
ginning was small, your end will increase greatly.'"
And Aaron the Priest knew that the death of his
sons was like the binding of Isaac, for Abraham, the
man of kindness, literally bound him with his own
hands[4] and took the knife to slaughter him and ex-
haust the power of judgment from his son Isaac, in
the mystery of "the waters conceived and gave birth
to darkness." So too here, Nadab and Abihu died to
uproot judgment—this is "God who is angry every
day." All the more so then, when the descent of the
Divine Presence into the lower realms was contrary
to the attribute of judgment,[5] as explained in the Zo-
har at the end of Parashat Pekudei. It was necessary

[1] I've added the bracketed clarification to indicate that 'She' refers to the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), which is grammatically feminine in Hebrew. This reflects the kabbalistic concept of the feminine aspect of divinity.

[2] This is a reference to the Talmudic statement (Berakhot 17b) that the entire world is sustained because of Rabbi Hanina ben Dosa. Here it's used to illustrate how the suffering of a righteous person can sustain the world.

[3] This metaphor illustrates how the righteous, while remaining essentially pure, may have some connection to impurity through their physical existence. Their suffering purifies these extended aspects.

[4] The text interprets the binding of Isaac (Akedah) and the deaths of Nadab and Abihu as divinely ordained events that channeled judgment in specific ways, suggesting that these apparent tragedies had cosmic purposes in balancing divine attributes.

[5] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the Tabernacle's purpose was to create a dwelling place for divinity in the physical world, which requires a mitigation of strict judgment to allow divine presence to coexist with material existence.

[i] The concept of 'sufferings of love' (yissurim shel ahavah) is a traditional rabbinic idea that certain suffering is sent not as punishment but as an expression of divine love to purify the righteous person and elevate them spiritually.

[ii] This is a reference to the Talmudic statement about Rabbi Hanina ben Dosa, whose extraordinary righteousness was said to sustain the entire world. The author uses this to illustrate how a righteous person's suffering can benefit everyone.

[iii] This mystical phrase 'the waters conceived and gave birth to darkness' appears to refer to the kabbalistic concept of how divine judgment (often symbolized by water) can manifest as darkness or suffering in the world.

[iv] This is a quote from Psalm 7:12, 'God is angry every day,' used here to illustrate the constant presence of divine judgment that must be addressed through spiritual actions.

היתה הפך מדת הדין כדפי׳ בזוהר סוף פ׳ פקודי. והוצרך ליתן מקום אל הדין להשפיעו שיטפל בו בענין איוב שפירשו בזוהר פרשת אמור. לכן וידום אהרן כאדם שמודה על העשוי כי הכל במשפט ישר מלבד כי ידע שעקר קדושת המשכן היה בקרבן נפש אדם דכתיב אדם כי יקריב מכם. הה״ד הוא אשר דבר ה׳ בקרובי אקדש. ועתה אהרן איש החסד קדשו בבניו. וזה וימותו לפני ה׳. ולא היו ראויים לאותו מעשה רק חטאם היה כדי לגלגל עליהם הדין כענין יסורי רבי שבאו על ידי מעשה וכבר נודע כי היו לכפרת הדור על כן כתיב ואחיכם כל בית ישראל יבכו את השריפה.[i] כי הבכיה מצד הדין לתקנו לעורר המים מצד החסד נגדו לכן הם יבכו הדין אשר שרף ה׳ והשפיע אל מקום יניקתם כדי שיתעוררו הרחמים עליהם כדוגמא זו יצתה בת קול ואמרה כל דהוה באשכבתיה דרבי מזומן לחיי העוה״ב[ii] כדאיתא בכתובות פ׳ י״ב ושם פירש״י מזומן פירוש בלא דין ובלא יסורים וכן פירשו בכל מקום וזו היתה כוונתו לזכות את הרבים בהספדו וצוויו בשעת מיתתו אל תספדוני בעיירות.[iii] [iv]

to give place to judgment, to channel it to be concerned with it, similar to the case of Job, as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Emor. Therefore, "Aaron was silent" like one who acknowledges what has been done,[1] for everything is with righteous judgment. Moreover, he knew that the essence of the Tabernacle's sanctity was in the sacrifice of a human soul, as it is written, "When a person from among you brings an offering." This is what is meant by "This is what the Lord spoke, saying: 'Through those near to Me I will be sanctified.'" And now Aaron, the man of kindness, was sanctified through his sons. This is "and they died before the Lord." They were not deserving of that deed, but their sin was to bring judgment upon them, similar to the sufferings of Rabbi [Judah the Prince] that came about through an incident. And it is already known that they were for the atonement of the generation, therefore it is written, "And your brethren, the entire house of Israel, shall weep for the burning." For weeping stems from judgment, to repair it and arouse the waters from the side of kindness against it. Therefore, they shall weep for the judgment that the Lord burned and channeled to the place of their nourishment, so that mercy would be aroused for them. Similar to this, a heavenly voice went forth and said, "Whoever was present at Rabbi's funeral is destined for the life of the World to Come," as stated in Tractate Ketubot, chapter 12. And there Rashi explained "destined" to mean without judgment and without suffering, and so they explained in every place. And this was his intention: to bring merit to the many through his

[1] Aaron's silence after the death of his sons (Leviticus 10:3) is interpreted here as his recognition of the cosmic necessity of their deaths, despite his personal grief.

[i] This is a quote from Leviticus 10:6, referring to how the entire house of Israel should mourn the burning of Nadab and Abihu. The author interprets this communal mourning as a means to transform divine judgment into mercy.

[ii] This Talmudic quote (Ketubot 103b) states that all who were present at Rabbi Judah the Prince's funeral were destined for the World to Come. The author interprets this as indicating that Rabbi's death and funeral served as an atonement for others.

[iii] This was Rabbi Judah the Prince's instruction before his death (Ketubot 103a), requesting that his eulogies not be delivered in small towns. The author suggests this was to benefit the maximum number of people with the merit of participating in his funeral.

[iv] Cf. Ezekiel 1 — The text draws on Ezekiel's vision of the four-faced divine chariot (merkavah) as a framework for understanding how righteous humans can embody different aspects of divine manifestation. The four faces (man, lion, ox, eagle) become spiritual archetypes that the righteous can perfect in themselves. | Cf. Song of Songs 8:6 — The phrase 'Set me as a seal' (שימני כחותם) is quoted from Song of Songs 8:6. In kabbalistic interpretation, this verse is understood as describing the unification of the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, specifically between Zeir Anpin and Malkhut. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The text refers explicitly to the Zohar's explanation

eulogy and his instruction at the time of his death: "Do not eulogize me in the towns."[1]

פרק ה׳

Chapter 5

לצד דרום מן המרכבה שם פן אריה[i] הם אותם השומרים משמרת הדרום בגמול חסדים תמיד שכל צד גמילות חסדים תלוי בחסד באשר פירשנו למעלה במאמרות הקודמים בגמילות חסדים הנעשה עם המתים. ואמרו בגמרא סוטה פרק ד׳ גדול גמ״ח יותר מן הצדקה ובגמרא ע״ג פרק קמא כל זמן שישראל עוסקים בתורה ובגמ״ח יצרם מסור בידם. ובאבלות שעושים על הנפטר מעוררים מעשיו הטובים שעשה בעולם. ובזה מגבירים מדת החסד ונודע כי בשעת פטירתו כל מעשיו נפרטים לפניו והוא

On the south side of the divine chariot is the face of a lion,[C][2] representing those who guard the southern watch through constant acts of loving-kindness,[3] for all aspects of loving-kindness depend on the attribute of Chesed, as we explained above in previous discourses concerning the loving-kindness performed for the dead. The Talmud states in Sotah, chapter 4, "Acts of loving-kindness are greater than charity," and in Avodah Zarah, chapter 1, "As long as Israel engages in Torah and acts of loving-kindness, their evil inclination is delivered into their hands." Through the mourning performed for the deceased, we awaken the memory of the good deeds they performed in this world, thereby strengthening the attribute of loving-kindness.[D] It is known that at the moment of death, all of one's deeds are enumerated before them, and they write

[C] Or: "lion-face aspect" — This more technical translation might better convey the kabbalistic concept of the divine 'faces' or aspects of the merkavah (divine chariot), though it is less natural in English.

[D] Or: "the sefirah of Chesed" — For a more technical kabbalistic rendering, this term could be translated using the specific sefirot terminology, though the current translation better conveys the meaning to readers unfamiliar with kabbalah.

[1] Rabbi Judah the Prince's instruction about his funeral arrangements is interpreted as his desire to maximize the spiritual benefit of his death for others, consistent with the text's overall theme that the deaths of the righteous serve greater cosmic purposes.

[2] The text is drawing from Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (merkavah) with four faces. In kabbalistic tradition, each face corresponds to a direction and divine attribute. The lion (south) represents Chesed (loving-kindness).

[3] The concept of 'watching' or 'guarding' (משמרת) a direction refers to cultivating the corresponding divine attribute through appropriate spiritual practices.

of how the Divine Presence descending to the Tabernacle represented a cosmic event that required balancing divine judgment with mercy. This illustrates how the author grounds his mystical interpretations in earlier kabbalistic sources. | Cf. Talmud, Tractate Ketubot 103b — The author quotes the Talmudic account of Rabbi Judah the Prince's death to illustrate how the death of a righteous person can serve as atonement for others, creating a connection between personal suffering and cosmic benefit. | Cf. Leviticus 10:1-3 — The author draws a parallel between the biblical account of Nadab and Abihu's death and the binding of Isaac, suggesting both were cosmic events that channeled divine judgment in particular ways. This exemplifies the author's approach of finding mystical patterns across seemingly disparate biblical narratives. | Cf. Genesis 22 — The binding of Isaac (Akedah) is interpreted kabbalistically as Abraham, the embodiment of divine kindness, participating in an act of judgment (binding his son) that ultimately transformed judgment into mercy. This illustrates the text's recurring theme of righteous suffering as a means of cosmic transformation.

[i] This draws on Ezekiel's vision (Ezekiel 1:10) of the divine chariot with four faces. The author is using this vision as an organizing principle to explain different spiritual virtues, with the lion face representing acts of loving-kindness (Chesed).

כותב וחותם עליהם כדאמרי׳ בגמרא תענית פ״ק. ובהספד מעוררים מעשיו להתראות לפני המלך ה׳ צבאות ועל החכם קורעין וחולצין ומברין כפי מה שמצאתי כתוב לחכם אחד שלהיות שהוא היה מקיים שאר כסות ועונה[i] היה עוסק בתורה ובעל מדות ומתפלל לעתות על הגזרות לכן קורעים על מדותיו המשולות לבגדיו הן קודמות אצל ההמון. חולצין על שנפטר מי שהיה חולץ מנעליו בהתפללו על צרות צבור. עוד היה מרחיק מעליו ככל האפשר לו לבוש עור הנחש להתלבש בכתנות אור.[ii] ומברין על שמת מי שהיה לומד תורה שהיא שאר לנפש.[iii] ומטוביה אוטיב לעמיה. ולהיות החכם הנאתו קרובה לכל העולם בנזכר לפיכך הכל חייבים בהספדו לכבדו. ובזה עושין כבוד לתורה וכבוד לנפש וכבוד לגופו וכמו שלחי שואלין בשלומו כדי לחזק ולהוסיף שלימות הנשאל וה״ה למי שמשיבין לו. כך ע״י ההספד שהם דברים של מיתה[iv]

and seal their acknowledgment of them, as stated in the Talmud, Taanit, first chapter. Through the eulogy, we awaken their deeds to appear before the King, the Lord of Hosts. 20R

For a deceased sage, we rend our garments, remove our shoes, and partake of the mourner's meal. As I found written by one sage: since the deceased fulfilled the obligations of "food, clothing, and conjugal rights"[1] through engaging in Torah study, possessing good character traits, and praying at times of harsh decrees, therefore we rend our garments for his virtues, which are likened to his garments and take precedence among the masses. We remove our shoes in honor of one who would remove his own shoes when praying for the community's troubles. Furthermore, he would distance himself as much as possible from the "garment of the serpent's skin" to clothe himself in "garments of light."[2] We partake of the mourner's meal because the deceased studied Torah, which is sustenance for the soul, and "from his goodness, he benefited his people." 25R 30R 35R

Since a sage's benefit extends to the entire world as mentioned, therefore everyone is obligated to honor him with a eulogy. In this way, we show honor to the Torah, honor to his soul, and honor to his body. Just as for the living, we inquire after their welfare to strengthen and add to the wholeness of the one being asked about (and the same applies to 40R 45R

[1]The Hebrew phrase 'שאר כסות ועונה' refers to the three biblical obligations of a husband to his wife from Exodus 21:10. The author creatively applies these material obligations to spiritual practices.
[2]This kabbalistic concept draws on an interpretation of Genesis 3:21 where 'garments of skin' (כתנות עור) given after the Fall replaced the original 'garments of light' (כתנות אור). The sage strives to reverse this process through spiritual discipline.

[i]These three terms refer to the biblical obligations of a husband to his wife (Exodus 21:10): food, clothing, and conjugal rights. The author creates an analogy between these physical obligations and the sage's spiritual obligations.
[ii]This refers to the kabbalistic interpretation of Genesis 3:21. Before Adam's sin, humans wore 'garments of light' (כתנות אור), but after sin, these became 'garments of skin' (כתנות עור). The change involves only the Hebrew vowel points between אור (light) and עור (skin).
[iii]A wordplay on 'שאר' (food/sustenance) and its metaphorical application to Torah as spiritual sustenance for the soul.
[iv]Cf. Sotah, chapter 4 — The author quotes this to establish the theological importance of acts of loving-kindness, particularly those performed for the dead, which is a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Avodah Zarah, chapter 1 — This reference supports the author's theological framework that proper ritual practices and Torah study create spiritual protection and power over negative forces. | Cf. Taanit, first chapter — The author uses this to establish the theological significance of the moment of death as a time of spiritual accounting, explaining why proper mourning practices are important for the deceased's soul. | Cf. Four faces of the divine chariot (Ezekiel 1) — The author uses this prophetic vision as an organizing principle, with each face representing a different spiritual virtue. In this passage, the lion face represents the attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness) associated with the south direction. | Cf. Garments of light vs. garments

the one who responds), so too through the eulogy, which consists of words concerning death

ילכו להם מלאכי חבלה כי נתקררה דעתם ונעשה רצונם בזה.[i] ואמרו בפרשת שלח לך דף קע״ב דמלאך המות נייחא שלו בהספדא דנשין איהו רקיד ואזניה להספדא.[ii] וכתב רבינו בחיי בפ׳ ויחי כי יש תשעה מינין של הספד כתובים בתורה בנביאים ובכתובים וכן עלו תשע כתות עם יוסף באבלו של אביו כדי להספיד עליו ט׳ מיני הספד. וממה שכתבנו למעלה בפראים שמתקבצים תשעה ותשעה יובן דעת וטעם לט׳ מיני הספד. וגם ראיתי קצת שמדקדקים בליל בעור חמץ לחזור אחר תשעה פרוסות של חמץ[iii] הגם שהוותיקין אומרים שטוב שיהיו י״א בסוד עשתי עשרה יריעות ע״ד כל המוסיף גורע. עוד על ידי ההספד מקילין צער המת ודוחקו כמ״ש בהקפות שהם למנוע מעליהם כחות המזיקים הקשים והאבלות הוא על צער וטרדת המת לפי ששורה רוח הטומאה על הגוף בסלוק הנשמה זולתי על הפרושים שנשמתם

...the angels of destruction will depart because their minds have been calmed and their will has been done. It is said in Parashat Shelach Lecha, page 172, that the Angel of Death finds satisfaction in the lamentations of women; he dances and inclines his ear to hear the eulogies. Rabbeinu Bachya wrote in Parashat Vayechi that there are nine types of eulogies written in the Torah, Prophets, and Writings, and similarly nine groups accompanied Joseph in his mourning for his father to deliver nine types of eulogies for him. From what we have written above about the "wild ones" who gather in groups of nine, one can understand the reasoning behind the nine types of eulogies. I have also seen some who are meticulous on the night of searching for chametz to look for nine pieces of chametz, although the pious ones say it is better to have eleven, corresponding to the secret of the eleven curtains, following the principle that "whoever adds, diminishes."

Furthermore, through eulogies, the deceased's suffering and distress are eased, as we explained regarding the circuits [around the bier],[1] which serve to keep away the severe harmful forces. The mourning is over the suffering and distress of the deceased, since the spirit of impurity rests upon the body when the soul departs,[2] except in the case of the ascetics whose souls are stored in the divine

[1] This refers to the Jewish custom of hakafot, where participants circle the deceased's bier before burial, typically seven times. The author sees these ritual circumambulations as having protective spiritual power.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that when the soul leaves, the body becomes spiritually vulnerable, attracting negative forces. This concept underlies many Jewish burial practices designed to protect the body and soul during this transition.

of skin (Genesis 3:21) — This reference creates a contrast between material existence (skin) and spiritual existence (light), suggesting that sages transcend physical limitations through Torah study and good deeds.

[i] This phrase refers to the kabbalistic concept that angels of destruction are satisfied or 'cooled' through proper eulogies, suggesting that ritualized mourning practices have cosmic effects in appeasing destructive forces.

[ii] This colorful description from the Zohar portrays the Angel of Death as finding satisfaction ('rest') in women's lamentations, even dancing and inclining his ear to hear them, suggesting a gendered aspect to effective funeral rituals.

[iii] The author connects funeral practices to the search for chametz (leavened bread) before Passover, suggesting a mystical correspondence between numbers in seemingly unrelated rituals. This reflects the kabbalistic tendency to find unified spiritual patterns across different ritual domains.

תלויה באוצר[i] גם שלא נתעכל
עדיין הבשר. עוד טעם האבלות
הוא להיות פרידה זאת ע״י
מלאך המות כי אם היתה המיתה
בפירוד הנפש מהגוף ובשוב כל
חלק למקומו לא היה ראוי כי
אם לשחוק אך דוה לבנו על
שליטת המשחית בצדיקים כמו
שאמרו בעשרה הרוגי מלכות
ולכן היו צועקים להחליש כח
החצונים בצעקתם ובקולם
קול עוז היו ממתיקים כחות
הדינים הקדושים משקיעים
בנוקבא דתהומא רבא דינים
החיצונים[ii] עד כי נהפך עליהם
מדת הדין רחמים ומיתתן היתה
קיום העולם כמו שיסד הפייטן
בפיוט אלה אזכרה וגו׳ שבסדר
ט׳ באב לספרדים ותקפו של
אבלות ג״כ הוא על צער שירגיש
המת במיתתו ואחר המיתה
ג״כ בשבעה עידנין דיחלפון
עלוי.[iii] וגז״ל פירוש שלשה
לבכי שבעה להספד שלשים
לגיהוץ הוא לפי שחמת נאנס
ונגזל ממלאך המות בעון הגזל
שגזל אדם הראשון מה שאינו
שלו. שהיה עור הנחש.[iv] ועתה

treasury even before their flesh has decomposed. 75R
Another reason for mourning is that this separation
occurs through the Angel of Death, for if death
were merely the separation of the soul from the
body with each part returning to its place, it would
be appropriate only to rejoice. But our hearts are 80R
sorrowful because the destroyer has power even
over the righteous, as was said regarding the Ten
Martyrs.[1] Therefore, they would cry out to weaken
the power of the external forces with their outcries,
and with their powerful voices they would sweeten 85R
the powers of the holy judgments, sinking the
external judgments into the great abyss[2] until the
attribute of judgment was transformed into mercy
for them. Their deaths sustained the world, as the
liturgical poet composed in the poem "These I Will 90R
Remember" in the Sephardic Tisha B'Av liturgy.

The intensity of mourning is also due to the
pain that the deceased feels at death and after
death during the seven periods that pass over him.
The explanation of "three days for weeping, seven 95R
for eulogizing, and thirty for pressing clothes"[3] is
because the deceased is coerced and robbed by
the Angel of Death due to the sin of theft that
Adam committed, taking what was not his—which
was the serpent's skin.[4] Now "the fool consumes 100R
his flesh and skin," and the Angel takes what is
his. These three divisions correspond to Nefesh,

[1]This refers to Aseret Harugei Malkhut, the ten prominent rabbis executed by the Romans, whose story forms an important part of the Yom Kippur and Tisha B'Av liturgy. Their deaths are understood as having cosmic significance.

[2]This is technical kabbalistic language describing how proper mourning rituals neutralize negative spiritual forces by 'sinking' them into the cosmic abyss (nokva de-tehoma rabba), rendering them powerless.

[3]These are the traditional Jewish mourning periods: the most intense mourning for three days, the shiva period of seven days, and the shloshim period of thirty days, during which laundering clothes was traditionally prohibited.

[4]This unusual interpretation of Adam's sin frames it as 'theft' of mortality (metaphorically, the serpent's skin). It suggests that physical embodiment itself was inappropriate, and death is simply the reclaiming of what humans were never meant to possess permanently.

[i]The text makes an exception for ascetics (perushim), suggesting their bodies don't attract impurity after death because their souls are already stored in a divine 'treasury' even while alive. This reflects the belief that extreme spiritual discipline creates a different relationship between body and soul.

[ii]This technical kabbalistic phrase describes the cosmic effect of proper mourning: the 'external judgments' (negative spiritual forces) are 'sunk into the great abyss,' neutralizing their power. This shows how human ritual actions are believed to affect metaphysical realities.

[iii]This phrase, with its Aramaic elements, refers to 'seven periods that pass over' the deceased, alluding to stages of post-mortem experience. It reflects the belief that the soul experiences different phases after death, corresponding to the mourning periods observed by the living.

[iv]This presents an unusual kabbalistic interpretation of Adam's sin as 'theft' of the serpent's

הכסיל אוכל את בשרו ועורו. ומדידיה נטיל. ושלש חילוקים אלו נגד נפש רוח נשמה שכלם לוקות במיתה[i] וג׳ לשונות כתיבי בצדיקים גויעה אסיפה ומיתה ולחזוק כל א׳ מהם מתראים בשעת פטירתן של צדיקים שלש כתות של מלאכי שלום. וברכות המלוים אותו נשאר לו שמירה מעולה גם אחר שנקבר. שהמצוה החיא להנאתו ולהגן עליו ולוויית המת וכל צרכיו [ii]

Ruach, and Neshamah,[1] all of which suffer in death. Three terms are written regarding the righteous: expiration, gathering, and death.[2] To strengthen each of these, three groups of angels of peace appear at the time of the righteous person's departure. The blessings of those who accompany him provide superior protection for him even after burial, for that commandment is for his benefit and protection. The funeral escort and all his needs...

הוא חסד ואמת כי בהם תתחזק נפשו בצרור החיים ואפי׳ בלווייה החיים אמרו בסוטה פרק ט׳[iii] כל שאינו מלוה ומתלוה כאלו שופך דמים וזהו דבר ששוה בחיים ובמתים ועוד אמרו שם כופין ללויה ששכר לויה אין לו שעור גם שיש שעור ללויה כמו שאמרו הרב לתלמיד

It is loving-kindness and truth, for through them his soul is strengthened in the bond of life. Even regarding the accompaniment of the living, they said in Sotah, chapter 9: "Whoever does not accompany others or allow himself to be accompanied, it is as if he sheds blood."[3] This principle applies equally to the living and the dead. They further said there: "One may compel people to perform the duty of accompaniment, for the reward for accompaniment is

[1]These are the three primary components of the soul in kabbalistic thought: Nefesh (vital soul connected to the body), Ruach (emotional/moral soul), and Neshamah (intellectual/divine soul). The text suggests each experiences death differently.

[2]The text notes that the Torah uses three different terms for the deaths of righteous individuals: gevi'ah (expiration), asifah (gathering), and mitah (death), suggesting these represent different aspects of the soul's transition.

[3]This striking metaphor from the Talmud elevates the importance of accompaniment from mere courtesy to a life-preserving mitzvah, suggesting that leaving someone to travel alone creates potential spiritual or physical danger.

skin, metaphorically representing the inappropriate assumption of physicality or mortality. This provides a mystical explanation for why the Angel of Death has a claim on human bodies.

[i]The text correlates the three traditional mourning periods (3 days, 7 days, 30 days) with the three primary soul components in kabbalah: nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul). This suggests each mourning period addresses a different aspect of the soul's post-mortem journey.

[ii]Cf. Parashat Shelach Lecha, Zohar page 172 — The author cites this Zohar passage to show that proper eulogies serve multiple purposes: they satisfy the Angel of Death (thus preventing further harm), provide comfort to mourners, and ease the deceased's spiritual transition. | Cf. Rabbeinu Bachya on Parashat Vayechi — The author uses this reference to establish a mystical framework for proper eulogizing, suggesting that the number nine has special significance in funeral practices. | Cf. Ten Martyrs (Aseret Harugei Malkhut) — The author refers to the Ten Martyrs to illustrate how even the deaths of the righteous involve suffering and the power of the 'destroyer', yet paradoxically serve as a mystical sustenance for the world. | Cf. Three days for weeping, seven for eulogizing, thirty for pressing clothes — The author offers a mystical interpretation of these traditional mourning periods, connecting them to the three levels of the soul (Nefesh, Ruach, Neshamah) and suggesting that each period addresses a different aspect of the soul's transition. | Cf. Adam's theft of the serpent's skin — The author frames death as a consequence of Adam's primordial sin, metaphorically described as theft of the 'serpent's skin,' suggesting that the Angel of Death is merely reclaiming what rightfully belongs to the realm of mortality.

[iii]The text refers to Tractate Sotah in the Babylonian Talmud, which discusses various religious laws and ethical teachings.

עד עיבורה של עיר חבר לחבר
עד תחום שבת[i] תלמיד לרב
שאינו מובהק עד פרסה. ברבו
מובהק ג׳ פרסאות.[ii] ולהיות
שאחר מיתת המת זכותו יותר
גדול לפי שכבר פרע מקצת
חובו[iii] לכן מותר להרבות
בהספדו קצת על מעשיו הטובים.
ברם לא יוסיף הרבה כמ״ש
בברכות פ״ב כשם שנפרעין מן
המתים נפרעים מן הספדנין ומן
העונים אחריהם. ופרש״י אם
ירבו או ימעטו משבחיו ואמרו
בשבת פי״ג ובמ״ק פ״ב שבניו
של אדם מתים על שלא בכה
והתאבל על אדם כשר. ונראה
במדרש אבכיר[iv] שההספד הוא
תקון למת כמ״ש כי אמרו על
מתושלח שהיו שונה תשע מאות
סדרי משנה[v] ביון שמת שמעו
קול רעש ברקיע שהיו עושין
לו הספד והיו יורדין דמעות
מעיני החיות על מקום פטירתו
ביון שראו כך עשו לו הספד
מלמטה. ועקר החנטה הנאמר
במתים[vi] הוא השם טוב העומד
לנצח ולא ירקב הפך שם רשעים.
והקבר הוא כלפי עומק רום.
והוא בקר לצדיקים בקר אערך
לך ואצפה שכן מדתו של הקב״ה

immeasurable." Nevertheless, there are prescribed limits for accompaniment, as they said: a teacher accompanying a student goes until the city limits; a colleague accompanying another colleague goes until the Sabbath boundary; a student accompanying a teacher who is not his primary instructor goes up to one parasang; and for one's primary teacher, three parasangs. 125R

Since after a person's death their merit is greater because they have already paid part of their debt,[1] it is permissible to somewhat embellish their eulogy regarding their good deeds. However, one should not exaggerate greatly, as stated in Berakhot, chapter 2: "Just as punishment is exacted from the dead,[2] so it is exacted from those who eulogize them and those who respond after them." Rashi explained: "If they exaggerate or diminish his praises." And they said in Shabbat, chapter 13, and in Mo'ed Katan, chapter 2, that a person's children may die because he did not weep and mourn for a worthy person. 130R 135R 140R

It appears in the Midrash Abkhir that the eulogy serves as a rectification for the deceased, as they said concerning Methuselah, who used to study nine hundred orders of Mishnah. When he died, they heard the sound of commotion in the heavens as they were conducting a eulogy for him, and tears fell from the eyes of the celestial beings[3] upon the place of his departure. When people saw this, they too conducted a eulogy below. 145R

The essential "embalming" mentioned regarding 150R

[1] This reflects the theological concept that death itself serves as partial atonement for sins, which explains why one may speak more generously of the deceased than of the living.
[2] This passage reflects the Jewish belief that inappropriate eulogies can harm the deceased in the afterlife, creating a theological framework where truth remains essential even after death.
[3] This vivid mythological image illustrates the cosmic significance of human death, particularly of the righteous, suggesting that heavenly beings mourn along with humans.

[i] The 'Sabbath boundary' (techum Shabbat) is the maximum distance (approximately 2,000 cubits or about 0.6 miles) that Jewish law permits one to travel outside a city on the Sabbath.
[ii] A 'parasang' is a Persian unit of distance equivalent to approximately 3.5-4 miles. The text describes how much further one should accompany a primary teacher (3 parasangs) compared to regular colleagues or other teachers.
[iii] This phrase metaphorically describes death as partial payment of one's spiritual debt, reflecting a view that the suffering experienced in dying itself serves as atonement.
[iv] Midrash Abkhir is a now-lost midrashic work known only through quotations in later medieval sources. The story about Methuselah is not found in surviving rabbinic literature.
[v] This is a symbolic number, as the standard Mishnah contains only six orders (sedarim). The number 900 emphasizes Methuselah's extraordinary scholarship and longevity.
[vi] The term 'embalming' (chanitah) is used metaphorically here, unlike its literal use in Genesis regarding Jacob and Joseph. The author reinterprets it as preserving one's good reputation rather than physical preservation.

בתחלה צדיק במשפט אמת ולאו
וותרן הוא וזה לתועלת הנשמה.
ולבסוף חסיד כי נכנס לפנים
155 מן השורה בדדרש רב הונא
פ״ק דר״ה ועד דו פתח ועד
דו סגיר רחמוהי קרובין ושדי
לא מצאנוהו שגיא כח בשעת
הדין כדא״ר פפא בפ״ק דע״ג
160 ברם קבר הרשעים הוא בעומק
תחת והוא רקב וקבר רשעים
נקרא קבר התהום. וקברם של
צדיקים נעלם למעלה ולבן
מסיימין מקום הקבר ומציינין
165 אותו כי קבר הגוף למטה מציין
עם קבר הנפש למעלה.[i] וע״כ
קראו במשנת שקלים ציון הקבר
נפש דאמרו בונין לו נפש על
קברו. והקבורה היא טמונה
170 מכחות הטומאה כי טמון בארץ
חבלו אז ומלכודתו עלי נתיב.
ואז מתחיל האבלות לפי שנכנס
ברשות דומה. ויש קצת סמך
למנהג שנשאר בידנו לבוף
175 מטתו של נפטר אפי׳ בזמן הזה
שמחשש שמא יאמרו שהוא חרש
נמנעו מכפיית כל מטות שבבית
מ״מ כופין אותה שמת עליה
משום הא דאמרי׳ בכתובות
180 פ״ה דא״ר ינאי על חתניה כפו
מטתו שאלמלא יהודה קיים[ii] לא
ביטל עונתו והשתא דיו לאבל
שיעמוד באבלו בכפיית מטת
המת לבד. וכוונת אלו מלבד
185 הנדרש למעלה הם בכלל ג״ח
המקשטים פן ג׳ מהמרכבה

the dead[1] refers to the good name that endures forever and does not decay, unlike the name of the wicked. The grave points toward the profound heights. For the righteous, it is morning—"In the morning I will arrange [my prayer] before You and watch expectantly"—for such is the way of the Holy One, blessed be He: first righteous in true judgment, not waiving [accountability], which benefits the soul; and ultimately gracious, going beyond the strict letter of the law, as Rabbi Huna expounded in the first chapter of Rosh Hashanah: "Before He opens [the case] and before He closes [it], His mercies are near." And [regarding] "Shaddai, we cannot find Him; He is great in power," at the time of judgment, as Rabbi Papa said in the first chapter of Avodah Zarah. 155R 160R 165R

However, the grave of the wicked is in the depths below, and it is decay, and the grave of the wicked is called "the grave of the abyss."[2] The graves of the righteous are concealed above, and therefore we mark the burial place and designate it, for the grave of the body below corresponds to the grave of the soul above. Thus they called it in the Mishnah of Shekalim "the marking of the grave as a soul," saying, "They build a nefesh [soul/monument] over his grave." 170R 175R

Burial conceals [the body] from impure forces, for it is hidden in the earth, its snare and trap upon the path. Then mourning begins, because [the deceased] has entered the domain of Dumah[3] [the angel of silence/death]. There is some support for the custom that has remained with us to overturn the bed of the deceased. Even nowadays, when due to concern that people might say the person is deaf, we refrain from overturning all beds in the house, nevertheless we 180R 185R

[1] The author reinterprets physical embalming metaphorically, suggesting that the true preservation after death is one's good reputation rather than the physical body.

[2] This creates a cosmic geography where the righteous and wicked experience fundamentally different afterlife destinations, with directional symbolism (upward vs. downward) representing spiritual states.

[3] In Jewish mystical tradition, Dumah is the angelic guardian of the deceased, whose name derives from the Hebrew word for 'silence.' This represents the transition of the deceased from the realm of the living to that of the dead.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that different components of the soul have different post-mortem destinations, with the nefesh (vital soul) remaining near the grave while higher soul aspects ascend to celestial realms.

[ii] This reference to Rabbi Yannai's instruction about his son-in-law Judah comes from the Talmud (Ketubot 62b) and relates to mourning customs. The overturned bed symbolizes the disruption of normal marital relations that would have occurred had the person still been alive.

שהוא פני אריה ובזה מרכבה מרקדה.[i] וחסד אל יגבר עלינו כל היום:[ii]

overturn the one upon which the person died, based on what is said in Ketubot, chapter 5, that Rabbi Yannai said regarding his son-in-law: "Overturn his bed,[1] for had Judah still been alive, he would not have neglected his conjugal duty." And now it suffices 190R for the mourner to fulfill his mourning by overturning only the bed of the deceased.

The purpose of these [practices], beyond what was expounded above, falls within the category of acts of loving-kindness that adorn the third face of 195R the Divine Chariot,[2] which is the face of the lion. Through this, the Chariot dances,[3] and "may God's loving-kindness prevail over us all day long."

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

קישוט הפן רביעי מכסא כבוד של יוצרנו ב״ה שהוא פני אדם הכולל כל הפנים זה יתוקן ויקושט ע״י עוסקי תורה[iii] וכל

The fourth aspect of our Creator's glorious throne, blessed be He, which is the face of man encompassing all faces, will be rectified and adorned through those who engage in Torah study. Anyone who preserves

[1]The custom of overturning beds during mourning symbolizes the disruption of normal life and particularly marital relations. The text explains how this practice evolved over time while maintaining its essential symbolism.

[2]This references the vision in Ezekiel 1, where the Divine Chariot has four faces (man, lion, ox, and eagle). The author connects funeral rituals to this mystical vision, suggesting they participate in cosmic realities.

[3]This poetic metaphor suggests that proper funeral rituals create joyful response in higher spiritual realms, transforming what appears sorrowful on earth into cosmic celebration.

[i]This poetic phrase references Ezekiel's vision of the Divine Chariot (merkavah) with its four faces, associating acts of kindness with the lion-face and suggesting that such acts cause the celestial chariot to 'dance' with joy.

[ii]Cf. Sotah 46b — The passage cites this Talmudic source to establish the religious significance of accompanying both the living and the dead, presenting it as a spiritual obligation rather than merely a social courtesy. | Cf. Berakhot 19a — This reference establishes the ethical boundaries of eulogy, warning that while praise is appropriate, exaggeration brings punishment to both the eulogizer and the audience, suggesting a cosmic balance where truth remains essential even in honoring the dead. | Cf. Midrash Abkhir on Methuselah — This reference to a now-lost midrashic work demonstrates the author's belief that eulogies have cosmic significance, with heavenly beings participating in mourning the righteous, suggesting a connection between earthly rituals and celestial responses. | Cf. Psalm 5:4 — The phrase 'morning I will arrange before You and watch expectantly' comes from this psalm and is reinterpreted in a mystical context to suggest that the righteous experience 'morning' (divine illumination) after death, while the wicked experience darkness. | Cf. Rosh Hashanah 17b — This reference establishes the theological principle that divine judgment combines justice and mercy, which the author applies to understanding the afterlife experience, suggesting that souls experience judgment followed by mercy. | Cf. Mishnah Shekalim 2:5 — The author uses this reference to develop the mystical idea that physical grave markers correspond to spiritual realities, with the physical grave below corresponding to the soul's resting place above. | Cf. Ezekiel's Vision of the Divine Chariot (Ezekiel 1) — The author interprets funeral practices through the mystical framework of the Divine Chariot (Merkavah), suggesting that acts of kindness toward the dead correspond to the lion-face of the chariot, thus elevating these rituals from mere customs to cosmic participation in divine structures.

[iii]This passage begins an extended discussion of Torah study as the means of adorning the 'face of man' aspect of the divine throne. In kabbalistic thought, the four faces of the divine chariot

השומר תורתו נשמתו משתמרת כדאמרי׳ במנחות פ׳ י״א ובפרט בתורה שבכתב כי היא בנויה על שמות הקב״ה ומדותיו סוד האצילות שהוא האלהות ובשכרה דרשו במס׳ מנחות פ׳ י״א בפ׳ ונחת שלחנך מלא דשן יע״ש ובפ׳ חלק אמרו שהמשחיר פניו על ד״ת בעה״ז לעה״ב הקב״ה מבהיק זיוו. ובברכות פ״ב אמרי׳ כי אהלים של תורה מעלים את האדם מכף חובה לכף זכות והיא שם ה׳ ממש המטהר את ישראל וכתב בעל ספר עבודת הקדש בחלק היחוד פרק נ״א כי התורה התחילה בבי״ת וסיימה בלמ״ד נגד החכמה העליונה הכוללת ל״ב נתיבות שבה היה כל הוה וזו היא התורה שקדמה לעולם וממנה נאצלת מדת ת״ת סוד תורה שבכתב ותרי״ג מצות נאצלו מחכמה שקבלה מכתר בסוד תר״ך מיני מאורות שבאויר הקדמון[i] וכן אותיות עשרת הדברות הם תרי״ג מלבד אשר לרעך הרומזים לז׳ מצות דרבנן שעם ז׳ תיבות אלו הרומזים ג״כ לכללות הז׳ ספירות הם תר״ך. וכן נתנה בז׳ קולות ולכן שבעים פנים לתורה וכן תתבאר בשבעים פנים אלו באותיות ונקודות וטעמים מלבד התמורות בכ״ב אלפא ביתות ושערים פנים ואחור וחלוקי הנקודות שבכל תיבה ותיבה ומה שאמרו בברכות פ״ק זוכה לתורה שנתנה בחמשה קולות[ii] רומז אל מקום מחצבה

His Torah preserves their soul, as stated in Menachot, chapter 11. This is especially true regarding the Written Torah, for it is constructed upon the names of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His attributes—the secret of Atzilut, which is the Godhead itself. Concerning its reward, they expounded in Menachot, chapter 11, on the verse "and your table shall be full of fatness" (see there). And in chapter Chelek, they said that one who darkens their face over words of Torah[1] in this world, in the World to Come, the Holy One, blessed be He, will make their radiance shine forth. In Berakhot, chapter 2, they stated that the "tents" of Torah elevate a person from the scale of guilt to the scale of merit, for it is literally the Name of God that purifies Israel.

The author of Sefer Avodat HaKodesh wrote in the section on Unity, chapter 51, that the Torah begins with the letter Bet and ends with Lamed, corresponding to the supernal Wisdom that encompasses the 32 paths through which all existence came to be. This is the Torah that preceded the world, and from it emanates the attribute of Tiferet, the secret of the Written Torah.[2] The 613 commandments emanated from Wisdom, which received from Keter, in the secret of the 620 types of illuminations in the primordial atmosphere. Similarly, the letters of the Ten Commandments number 613, excluding "that belongs to your neighbor," which alludes to the seven rabbinic commandments. Together with these seven words, which also allude to the totality of the seven sefirot, they equal 620.

The Torah was given with seven voices, thus there are seventy facets to the Torah. These seventy facets are revealed through letters, vowel points, and cantillation marks, in addition to the permutations of the twenty-two alphabets, the gates of forward and backward arrangements, and the various vowel combinations possible in each and every word. Regarding

[1] This phrase refers to the Talmudic concept of one who 'makes their face black' through the intense effort of Torah study, suggesting dedication to the point of physical exhaustion.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) is the central sefirah that balances and integrates the various divine attributes. Its association with Written Torah establishes Torah as the central balancing force in the divine cosmic structure.

(man, lion, ox, eagle) correspond to different divine attributes, with the human face representing the highest integration of all attributes.

[i] The number 620 (תר״ך) is significant in kabbalah as the sum of the 613 biblical commandments plus the 7 rabbinic commandments. This passage connects this number to primordial divine light, suggesting that the commandments are manifestations of original divine illumination.

[ii] The five voices here likely refer to the five divine utterances at Sinai corresponding to the five

נהר היוצא מעדן ה״א ראשונה
ולזה כוללת חמשים שערי
בינה ויודעיה דורשים אותה
במ״ט פנים טהור וכו׳ כי שער
החמשים לא הושג אפי׳ למרע״ה
כדאמרי׳ במס׳ שבת. ולזה נתנה
בה׳ חומשים. א״כ התורה היא
כלל האדם העליון ולזה כוללת
רמ״ח מצות עשה ושס״ה מצות
לא תעשה כמנין אבריו וגידיו של
אדם תחתון ועליון ולפי שהתורה
צורת האדם היתה ראויה לאדם
ובה האדם אדם ולבסוף ידבק
בה האדם ואמרו בר״מ פ׳ פנחס
דף רכ״ב ע״ב כי תרי״ג מלאכים
סלקין לה לנשמתא בדיוקנין
כולהו ופניהם וכנפיהם פרודות
לקיים ואשא אתכם על כנפי
נשרים. וכ״ב אותיות שנבנית
בהם הם כבוד ה׳ וכבוד אלהים.
ולתקון וביסום והמתקת והכנעת
ד׳ מיני יצה״ר שאמרנו באו בה
ד׳ מדרגות ובד׳ מיני אמירות
נאמרו כללותיה ופרטיה.
המדרגה העליונה שבכלן היא
מדרגת אדון הנביאים ולא
איכא מידי בנביאי וכתובי דלא
רמיזא בדאורייתא כדתמה ר׳
יוחנן בגמרא עד שתרצה לו
בריה דר״ל. השניה נבואת
שאר נביאים. השלישית למטה
מאלה מדרגת רוח הקדש. וכבר
נתבארו במקומן מוצא כל אחד
מהם. אמנם רוח הקדש הוא
במלכות בית דוד שהרוח בא
אליה מהקדש סוד חכמת אלהים
וממנה נאצל על אנשיה הדברים
ברוח הקדש ודוד הוא הראש
כי מלא אחרי ה׳ ועשה שם
ועליה אמר רוח ה׳ דבר בי

what they said in Berakhot, chapter 1, that one merits the Torah that was given with five voices—this alludes to its source, the river flowing from Eden, the first Hei [of the divine name]. For this reason, it encompasses fifty gates of Understanding,[1] and those who know it interpret it in forty-nine ways of purity, etc., since even Moses our teacher did not attain the fiftieth gate, as stated in Shabbat. This is why it was given in five books.

Thus, the Torah is the entirety of the supernal Man, and therefore it contains 248 positive commandments and 365 negative commandments, corresponding to the limbs and sinews of the human being, both earthly and celestial. Since the Torah is the form of man, it is fitting for man, and through it, man is truly human, and ultimately man cleaves to it.[2] In Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Pinchas, page 222b, it states that 613 angels elevate the soul in all their forms, "and their faces and their wings were separated," fulfilling "I have carried you on eagles' wings." The twenty-two letters with which it is constructed are the glory of God and the glory of the Divine.

For the rectification, sweetening, amelioration, and subjugation of the four types of evil inclination we mentioned, the Torah contains four levels, and its general principles and details were expressed in four types of utterances. The highest level of all is that of the Master of Prophets [Moses], and there is nothing in the Prophets or Writings that is not hinted at in the Torah, as Rabbi Yochanan wondered in the Gemara until Rabbi Lakish's son explained it to him. The second level is the prophecy of the other prophets. The third level, below these, is the level of the Holy Spirit. The source of each has already been explained in its place.

The Holy Spirit resides in the kingdom of the House of David, as the spirit comes to it from the Holy—the secret of Divine Wisdom—and from it emanates upon its people the words spoken through the

[1] According to rabbinic tradition, Moses attained forty-nine of the fifty gates of Understanding (Binah), with the fiftieth remaining beyond human comprehension. This concept is used here to explain the mystical structure of Torah interpretation.

[2] The concept of 'cleaving' (devekut) to Torah is central to Jewish mysticism, suggesting not merely intellectual study but spiritual unification with divine wisdom.

books of Moses. In kabbalistic thought, these are connected to the first letter ה (hei) of the divine name, which represents Binah (Understanding) and is associated with the number 50, referring to the 50 gates of understanding.

ומלתו על לשוני. ואחריו שלמה
חכם כי הוא מלט את העיר
עיר ה׳ צבאות אלהינו בחכמתו
ולמטה מהם שאר המדברים
ברוח הקדש[i] שכן הכלה הכלולה
מהכל הרבה בחינות יש בה.
ואין לנו עסק עתה בבת קול
שנשתמשו בה החכמים הגדולים
אחר סלוק רוח הקדש מישראל
כדאיתא בשלהי דסוטה. וגורי
האר״י דרשו שתורה שהיא נבואת
מרע״ה היא בזעיר ונבואת שאר
הנביאים היא בנ״ה המתלבשים
בהיכלות ולכן אין שום נביא
רשאי לשנות מן התורה אפי׳ אות
אחת כי לא השיגו בתלמוד תורה
כי אם משה בהיות זעיר פנים אל
פנים עם מלכות. ושאר הנביאים
מתנבאים מנצח הוד מעצמם
כי אפי׳ שמואל שהיה מתנבא
מנ״ה בהגלות המדות עליונות
בהם ולזה היה משיג במדות
העליונות תוך נ״ה ולכן הוא
דוקא נקרא הרואה. ואולי זה
יהיה טעם ששקלו הכתוב כמשה
ואהרן כי היה משיג בנ״ה דוגמת
השגות משה ואהרן למעלה. אך
בת״ת בנזכר שהיא אספקלריא
המאירה נגש משה לבדו אל ה׳.
ורוח הקדש הוא ביסוד. ובת
קול היא במלכות כי קול הוא
בבינה ומלכות היא בתאותו
הקול. ופרש״י בגמ׳ דסוטה פ״ב
בת קול נקרא בגמ׳ ססמגור
והוא שם תולעת שמצוי בארז
וגוררתו מבפנים ומקצתו קיים
כך קצת מזיו שכינה היה נראה
להם לא כולו ובתוס׳ פירשו
שלא היו שומעין קול היוצא מן
השמים אלא קול אחר היוצא

Holy Spirit. David is the head, for he followed the Lord completely and established a name, and concerning this he said, "The spirit of the Lord spoke through me, and His word was on my tongue." After him came Solomon the Wise, for he saved the city, the city of the Lord of Hosts our God, through his wisdom. Below them are the others who spoke with the Holy Spirit, for the Bride, who incorporates everything, has many aspects.

We are not concerned now with the Bat Kol (Heavenly Voice) that the great sages used after the Holy Spirit departed from Israel, as stated at the end of Sotah. The disciples of the ARI taught that the Torah, which is the prophecy of Moses our teacher, is in Zeir Anpin, while the prophecy of the other prophets is in Netzach and Hod, which are clothed in the Heikhalot (celestial palaces). Therefore, no prophet is permitted to change even a single letter of the Torah, for they did not attain the level of Torah study that Moses did, as Zeir Anpin was face to face with Malkhut. The other prophets prophesied from Netzach and Hod themselves, for even Samuel, who prophesied from Netzach and Hod when the supernal attributes were revealed in them, attained the supernal attributes within Netzach and Hod, and therefore he specifically was called "the Seer." Perhaps this is the reason why Scripture equated him with Moses and Aaron, for he attained in Netzach and Hod similar to the attainments of Moses and Aaron above. But in Tiferet, which is the luminous lens, only Moses approached the Lord. The Holy Spirit is in Yesod, and the Bat Kol is in Malkhut, for voice is in Binah and Malkhut is in its desire, the voice.

Rashi explained in Sotah, chapter 2, that Bat Kol is called "sasmgor" in the Gemara,[1] which is the name of a worm found in cedars that hollows them from within, leaving part intact. Similarly, only part of the radiance of the Divine Presence was visible to them, not all of it. Tosafot explained that they

[1] This unusual term appears to be a hapax legomenon (word appearing only once) in rabbinic literature. The author provides its etymology as referring to a worm that hollows cedar trees from within, serving as a metaphor for how the heavenly voice represents only a partial revelation of divine will.

[i] The text establishes a clear hierarchy of prophecy: Moses at the highest level, followed by other biblical prophets, then those with ruach hakodesh (like David and Solomon), and finally (though not discussed in detail here) those who received bat kol (heavenly voice) after prophetic revelation ceased in Israel.

ממנו ולבן נקרא בת קול. ומה שהיו משיגים הנביאים במדות היה בהתלבשם למטה לבן עתיק שהשיג דניאל הוא עתיק שבעשיה ויחזקאל השיג ביצירה ט׳ מראות וכשהגיע למדרגת הכתר שבה נפל על פניו ואליהו השיג בבריאה[i] וזה שאמרו בזוהר אליהו למטה מהאי באר איהו שבאר הוא מלכות ואליהו למטה שהוא בריאה: [ii]

did not hear a voice coming from heaven but rather another voice emanating from it, and therefore it is called Bat Kol [daughter of a voice]. 125R

What the prophets attained in the divine attributes was through their embodiment below. Thus, the "Ancient One" that Daniel perceived is the Ancient One of Asiyah, and Ezekiel perceived in Yetzirah nine visions, and when he reached the level of Keter within it, he fell on his face. Elijah perceived in Beriah, and this is what they said in the Zohar: "Elijah is below this well," for the well is Malkhut, and Elijah is below, which is Beriah. 130R

פרק ז׳

Chapter 7

תורה מאתי תצא לכל אחוזת רעי ומרחמי באשר קבלתי מפי מורי הגאון מפאנו זצ״ל[iii] אשר היה ראשון לכל דבר שבקדושה וכל ימיו שמש חכמים בעמידה ובישיבה ונהירן ליה שבילי דנהרדיעה[iv] והיה מרגלא בפומיה. וכמו כן בפי המקובל כמהר״ר ישראל סרוק זצ״ל[v] כי

Torah shall go forth from me to all my companions and beloved friends,[1] as I received from my teacher, the Gaon of Fano of blessed memory, who was foremost in all matters of holiness. All his days he served the sages while standing and sitting, and the pathways of Nehardea were illuminated to him,[A] and it was frequently in his mouth. Similarly, from the Kabbalist Rabbi Israel Sarug of blessed memory, [I learned] that how shall a servant of flesh 5R

[A] Or: "and the pathways of Nehardea were clear to him" — The Aramaic expression 'נהירן ליה' can be translated as either 'illuminated to him' or 'clear to him.' The latter is more idiomatic in English and conveys that the teacher had mastery of the scholarly traditions of Nehardea, a famous Babylonian center of Jewish learning.

[1] The opening phrase alludes to Isaiah 2:3, 'For out of Zion shall go forth the law,' adapting it to indicate the author's role in transmitting teachings to his circle.

[i] This passage maps different prophets to specific levels in the kabbalistic cosmology: Daniel perceived Atik (Ancient One) in Asiyah (the lowest world), Ezekiel perceived visions in Yetzirah (Formation), and Elijah perceived in Beriah (Creation). This creates a hierarchical understanding of prophetic attainment corresponding to the four worlds of kabbalah.

[ii] Cf. Sefer Avodat HaKodesh — The text cites this work to establish the connection between the structure of the Torah and the 32 paths of wisdom in Kabbalah, showing how the physical book reflects cosmic structures. | Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna — This reference connects Torah study to the mystical process of soul elevation, explaining how engagement with Torah creates spiritual entities that support the soul's ascent through higher realms. | Cf. Menachot — The text cites this Talmudic passage to establish the tangible rewards of Torah study both in this world and the next, using rabbinic authority to support kabbalistic claims. | Cf. Zohar — The text uses this Zoharic reference to map prophetic attainment to specific levels in the kabbalistic cosmology, placing Elijah's prophetic vision at the level of Beriah (Creation) rather than higher levels.

[iii] This refers to Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano (1548-1620), an important Italian kabbalist who combined the teachings of Moses Cordovero with Lurianic Kabbalah, and whose works were highly influential in Italian Jewish mystical circles.

[iv] Nehardea was a major center of Jewish learning in Babylonia. This Aramaic expression, literally 'the paths of Nehardea were illuminated to him,' indicates mastery of complex Talmudic knowledge.

[v] Rabbi Israel Sarug was a kabbalist who spread Lurianic teachings throughout Italy and other European communities in the late 16th century. His connection to the author establishes a direct lineage to Lurianic Kabbalah.

במה יתרצה עבד ב״ו אל אדוניו מלכו של עולם בתחנותיו ובתפלותיו אם לא בפתוח פה ולהניד שפה בספורי אמירי קדוש ישראל בפסוקים המשולשים בתורה נביאים וכתובים כי בהם ימלא כבוד ה׳ את כל הארץ ויחד יסולו אמרותיהם לחזות בנועם ה׳ ולבקר בהיכלו ובהם נכרתים הזלזלים במזמרות ובהם חפץ הבוחר בשירי זמרה. כי בכחם הנאדרי הם זמיר עריצים ואז תפלתו תהיה כעתר להפוך מדותיו של הקב״ה ממדת רגזנות לרחמנות[i] כדאמרי׳ ביבמות פ״ו. כי למה לנו להרבות דברים משולבים מדעתנו יתמי דיתמי כמוני היום דלאו כר׳ לוי אנא דאמר במדרש שיר השירים דידע למחרז וידע למקדש.[ii] ברם מכיר אני את מקומי שהנני כקטן שיש לו מעשה ואין לו מחשבה. ולהיות כי האלהים בשמים ואנו על הארץ על כן יהיו דברים המוחרזים מדעתנו מועטים

and blood find favor with his Master, the King of the Universe, in his supplications and prayers, if not by opening his mouth and moving his lips with the sayings and utterances of the Holy One of Israel in the verses tripled in Torah, Prophets, and Writings?[1] For through them the glory of the Lord fills the entire earth, and together their words pave a path to behold the pleasantness of the Lord and to visit His temple. Through them the tendrils are cut with pruning hooks, and in them delights the One who chooses songs of praise. For with their mighty power they prune the tyrants,[A] and then one's prayer will be like a pitchfork,[2] turning the attributes of the Holy One, blessed be He, from the attribute of wrath to the attribute of mercy, as we say in Yevamot, chapter 6. For why should we multiply interwoven words from our own understanding, orphans of orphans like myself today,[3] for I am not like Rabbi Levi, who said in the Midrash on Song of Songs that he knew how to rhyme and how to sanctify.[B] However, I recognize my place, that I am like a child who has deeds but no thought. And since God is in heaven and we are on earth, therefore the words composed from our understanding shall be few before Him.

[A] Or: "with their majestic power they cut down oppressors" — The Hebrew 'נאדרי' has connotations of majesty and glory beyond mere might, and 'זמיר עריצים' is a biblical allusion to pruning or cutting down oppressive forces. This translation better captures both the majesty of scripture and its power against negative spiritual forces.

[B] Or: "in the Midrash on Song of Songs that he knew how to compose verse and how to craft sacred words" — The terms 'למחרז' and 'למקדש' are technical terms for poetic composition. This alternate translation more clearly conveys the poetic skills being referenced, emphasizing the literary artistry rather than just rhyming.

[1] The author is referring to the practice of collecting verses on the same theme from all three sections of the Hebrew Bible to create comprehensive prayer sequences, a method used extensively throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[2] This uses a play on the Hebrew word 'עתר' which can mean both 'pitchfork' and 'prayer/supplication.' The metaphor suggests that prayer turns over divine attributes as a pitchfork turns soil.

[3] A self-deprecating phrase expressing extreme humility, suggesting the author sees himself as doubly removed from authoritative tradition, yet this rhetorical humility was conventional in rabbinic writing while still asserting one's teachings.

[i] This metaphor compares prayer to a pitchfork (עתר) that turns over soil, suggesting that properly composed prayer has the power to transform divine judgment into mercy. This concept derives from the Talmud (Yevamot 64a).

[ii] The author contrasts himself with Rabbi Levi, who according to the midrash had special skill in composing both poetic verse (למחרז) and sacred liturgy (למקדש), thus emphasizing the author's humility while discussing matters of prayer composition.

[i] לפניו

כי גם בלא דעת נפש לא טוב כדאמרי׳ בפ׳ אין עומדין א״ר יהושע בשם ר״מ לעולם יהיו דבריו של אדם מועטין לפני הקב״ה שנאמר אל תבהל על פיך וגו׳. והפילוסוף כתב כי השיר מענג הטבע ונמצא להמשיך לבות השומעים והקדמונים הגידו על אורפי״או[ii] שהיה כל כך שלם ובקי בנגונו ושירו שהיו כל מיני בני אדם גדולים וקטנים בוערים וחכמים סרים אל משמעתו. והחכם אברבניל״ו[iii] כתב בפ׳ בשלח שמוצא השירים שקולים הנעשים במדה במשקל לא מצאנו מהם דבר בדברי הנביאים וגם לא מחכמי המשנה והגמ׳ כי היה התחלתו בגלותנו בין חכמי ישראל שלמדו ממלאכת הישמעאלים ויעשו גם המה בחכמה וליה לא ס״ל מה שכ׳ הרא״ש בפיוטי הקליר[iv] כדלקמן. וגם החכם אבן עזרא[v] לא כן ידמה כי הפליא לדבר נגד איזה פיוטים

For even without knowledge, a soul is not good, as they said in chapter "Ein Omdin" [Berakhot 61a]: "Rabbi Joshua said in the name of Rabbi Meir: A person's words should always be few before the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is said, 'Do not be hasty with your mouth' [Ecclesiastes 5:1]." The philosopher [Aristotle] wrote that poetry delights human nature and is found to draw the hearts of listeners. The ancients told of Orpheus, who was so accomplished and expert in his music and song that all kinds of people—great and small, ignorant and wise—would submit to his authority. The sage Abravanel wrote in his commentary on Parashat Beshalach that we do not find any metered poetry composed with measure and rhythm in the words of the Prophets, nor among the Sages of the Mishnah and Talmud, for its beginning was during our exile among the Jewish scholars who learned this craft from the Muslims and they too engaged in this art. He did not hold the view that the Ra'osh wrote regarding the liturgical poems of Kallir, as will be discussed below.[A] The sage Ibn Ezra likewise did not agree, for he spoke extensively against certain liturgical poems attributed to Kallir in his commentary on the verse "Do not be hasty with your mouth." Go and see his words there.[B] Nevertheless,

[A] Or: "He disagreed with what the Rosh wrote about Kallir's liturgical poems, as will be explained later" — The abbreviation 'ס״ל' (savira lei) means 'he holds the opinion' and the negation indicates disagreement. This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the disagreement, which might be clearer for readers unfamiliar with rabbinic terminology.

[B] Or: "Go check out his words on this matter" — This is a Talmudic Aramaic expression often used to direct readers to examine a source. While the original translation is accurate, this alternate translation uses more contemporary language that might be more accessible to modern readers.

[i] Cf. Song of Songs — The author cites this to establish a contrast between Rabbi Levi's poetic expertise and his own self-perceived inadequacy, showing humility while still establishing a connection to respected rabbinic tradition | Cf. Yevamot — The author cites this Talmudic passage to establish the power of properly composed prayer to affect divine attributes, transforming judgment to mercy—a key theological concept underlying his approach to prayer composition | Cf. Nehardea — This reference establishes the author's teacher as master of the scholarly tradition of Nehardea, an important Babylonian center of Jewish learning, thereby establishing the scholarly lineage and authority of the author's teachings

[ii] A reference to Orpheus, the legendary musician and poet from Greek mythology who could charm all living things with his music.

[iii] Don Isaac Abravanel (1437-1508), prominent Jewish statesman, philosopher, and biblical commentator who served in the courts of Portugal, Spain, and Italy.

[iv] Eleazar Kallir (or Kalir), an influential Hebrew liturgical poet who lived approximately in the 6th-7th century CE, known for his complex and innovative poetry for Jewish holidays.

[v] Rabbi Abraham Ibn Ezra (1089-1167), one of the most distinguished Jewish biblical commentators and poets of medieval Spain.

המיוחסים לקלירי בפסוק אל
תבהל על פיך. פוק חזי דבריו
משם. ברם אמינא ומחוינא
כי דברי הראשונים בחרוזים
שנתפשטו בדור ישראל אפי׳
אדם אחר אמרן היית צריך לכוף
אזניך ולשמוע דבריהם כי נעמו.
הלא החכם אבן עזרא עצמו
שהפליא לדבר נגד הפייטנים
שבח הבקשות מהגאון רב סעדיה
דאמר שלא חבר מחבר כמוהם.
והם על לשון המקרא ודקדוק
הלשון. באין חידוש ומשלים
ולא דרוש. והפיוטים ששערום
הראשונים וקיימום וקבלום
עליהם היהודים[i] אין לזוז מהם
ואין לשנות מנהג המקום [ii]

I say and demonstrate[A] that the words of the early authorities in poetic form that have spread throughout the generations of Israel, even if another person composed them, you should bend your ear and listen to their words, for they are pleasant. Indeed, Ibn Ezra himself, who spoke extensively against the liturgical poets, praised the supplications of the Gaon Rav Saadia, saying that no composer has composed like them. And they follow the biblical language and grammatical precision, without novelty, parables, or homiletics. As for the liturgical poems that the early authorities composed and established, and which the Jews accepted upon themselves, one should not deviate from them nor change the custom of the place.

כדפסק בעל ההגהות סי׳
תרי״ט[iii] שכתב וז״ל אל ישנה
אדם ממנהג העיר אפי׳ בנגונים
או בפיוטים שאומרים שם.
והם דברי מהרי״ל[iv] ואתרע
ביה מלתא והצדיק עליו הדין
משום ששונה מנהג המקום
לומר סליחה בלתי נהוגה
וכתוב בלקוטים שהם בסוף
ספר עשרה שליטים[v] על זה

As ruled by the author of Haggahot in section 619, who wrote: "A person should not deviate from the custom of the city, even regarding melodies or liturgical poems[B] recited there." These are the words of Maharil, and misfortune befell him, and he accepted divine judgment upon himself because he changed the local custom by reciting an uncommon penitential prayer. It is written in the collected notes at the end of Sefer Asarah Shalitim regarding this: "Therefore, one should be careful not to

[A] Or: "However, I assert and will show" — This Aramaic expression introduces the author's own position in contrast to the views just cited. The alternate translation emphasizes the author's intention to not just state but prove his position, which might better capture the rhetorical force.

[B] Or: "melodies or piyyutim" — The Hebrew term 'piyyutim' is sometimes retained in English scholarly writing about Jewish liturgical poetry. While 'liturgical poems' is more accessible, 'piyyutim' preserves the technical nature of the term.

[i] This phrasing echoes Esther 9:27, which describes how the Jews accepted the observance of Purim. The author employs this biblical language to give weight to the acceptance of liturgical poems by the Jewish community.

[ii] Cf. Berakhot 61a — The author uses this Talmudic citation to establish the traditional Jewish value of brevity in prayer, setting up his discussion about the appropriate style and length of liturgical poetry. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 5:1 — This biblical verse serves as the foundation for the rabbinic teaching about brevity in prayer, which the author uses to frame his discussion of liturgical poetry. | Cf. Ibn Ezra's commentary on Ecclesiastes 5:1 — The author acknowledges Ibn Ezra's critique of elaborate liturgical poetry as potentially contradicting the biblical instruction for brevity in prayer, though he will go on to defend such poetry. | Cf. Rosh's comments on Kallir's piyyutim — The author references an ongoing medieval debate about the propriety of elaborate liturgical poetry, noting that Abravanel and Ibn Ezra took positions against such poetry, while the Rosh defended it.

[iii] This refers to the ruling of Rabbi Moshe Isserles (Rema), who wrote glosses on the Shulchan Aruch, specifically section 619 which discusses Yom Kippur customs.

[iv] Acronym for Rabbi Jacob ben Moses Moelin (c. 1365-1427), a major German rabbinic authority whose customs became influential throughout Ashkenazic communities.

[v] "Book of Ten Rulers," a collection of rabbinic works. The title alludes to Ecclesiastes 7:19.

לכן ידקדק אדם שלא להחליף
שום תנא או אמורא או שום
פיוט ושיר ושבח וכו׳ ואולי
אמרו בזה כי נקרא משיג גבול
עולים[i] לרמוז לשכינה שיושבת
על תהלות ישראל ומלאכים
עליונים שעולים ויורדים שמה
והם חברים מקשיבים לתפלות
ישראל. ופוק חזי מאי עמא
דבר. ואמרו בגמ׳ דסוטה פ״ב
דר׳ זירא אמר לר׳ ירמיה
לא תפיק נפשך לבר מהלכתא
ופרש״י כל דברי חכמים שנקבעו
אל תהרהר אחריהם וכ״ש אם
הקליר[ii] היה ר׳ אלעזר בן ערך
כדברי הרשב״א[iii] ואמר שהוא
ג״כ קרובי[iv] פי׳ הערוך[v] דרשן.
או ר׳ אלעזר בר׳ שמעון דאפי׳
רשב״י קראו נר ישראל ב׳
פעמים בערכין פ״ב כפי דברי
הרא״ש[vi] סוף פרק אין עומדין.
והביא ראיה מהפסיקתא דאמר
כד דמך רבי אליעזר בר״ש
קרא עליו דורו מכל אבקת
רוכל דהוא תנא קרובין פייטן
ודרשן והוא תקן קרובות וכן
בתוס׳ פ׳ כל הבשר כתב ר״ת
כי הוא רבי אלעזר הקליר
בתוס׳ טוך. וכבר כתבנו דעת
החכם אבן עזרא והאברבניל״ו
ז״ל כי לא שמיעא להו הכי
וכזה כתב המגיה לספר יוחסין
וז״ל. אמר שמואל כבר כתבתי

substitute any Tanna or Amora, or any liturgical
poem, song, or praise, etc." Perhaps they said about 85R
this that one who does so is called "encroaching
upon the boundary of those who ascend,"[A] alluding
to the Divine Presence that dwells upon the praises
of Israel and the supernal angels who ascend
and descend there, who are companions listening 90R
attentively to the prayers of Israel. Go and see
what the people practice. And they said in the
Gemara of Sotah, chapter 2, that Rabbi Zeira said
to Rabbi Yirmiyah, "Do not take yourself outside
the established law," and Rashi explained: "Do not 95R
question any words of the Sages that have been
established." This is especially true if Kallir was
Rabbi Elazar ben Arakh, according to the Rashba,
who said that he was also a composer of kerovot,
which the Arukh explains means a preacher. Or if 100R
he was Rabbi Elazar son of Rabbi Shimon, whom
even Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai called "the light of
Israel" twice in Arakhin, chapter 2, according to
the Rosh at the end of the chapter "Ein Omdin."
And he brought proof from the Pesikta, which says: 105R
"When Rabbi Eliezer son of Rabbi Shimon died,
his generation proclaimed about him 'all powders
of the merchant,' for he was a Tanna, a composer
of kerovot, a liturgical poet, and a preacher, and
he established the kerovot prayers." And similarly 110R
in Tosafot in the chapter "Kol Habasar," Rabbeinu
Tam wrote that he was Rabbi Elazar HaKallir, in
the Tosafot of Tukh.[1] And we have already written
the opinion of the wise Ibn Ezra and Abarbanel,
of blessed memory, for they did not hear it thus. 115R
And similarly wrote the editor of Sefer Yuchasin,

[A] Or: "transgressing the boundary of the ascenders" — This mystical phrase could be translated more literally to preserve its enigmatic quality, which refers to interfering with the pathway of prayers or souls that ascend to heaven.

[1] Tosafot Tukh refers to a specific commentary on the Talmud attributed to Rabbi Eliezer of Touques, a 13th-century French Tosafist.

[i] A mystical concept suggesting that changing established prayers interferes with the cosmic channels through which prayers ascend to heaven.

[ii] Rabbi Eleazar HaKallir, an influential early Jewish liturgical poet (paytan) whose identity and exact time period are subjects of scholarly debate.

[iii] Acronym for Rabbi Shlomo ben Aderet (1235-1310), a major Spanish Talmudic authority.

[iv] Liturgical poems added to the regular prayer service, particularly on holidays and special occasions.

[v] An important early lexicon of Talmudic terms compiled by Rabbi Nathan ben Yechiel of Rome (11th century).

[vi] Acronym for Rabbi Asher ben Yechiel (c. 1250-1327), an influential German-Spanish Talmudic scholar.

למעלה כי מצאתי בקרובה
אחת של יום שביעי של פסח
ראש תבותיה אני אלעזר ברבי
יעקב הקליר מקרית ספר.[i] וגם
הרא״ש מדעת עצמו ס״ל שהיה
זה שאמר בסוף פרק הנזכר וכן
ר׳ אלעזר הקליר שהיה מארץ
ישראל מקרית ספר ובימיו היו
מקדשין על פי הראיה שהרי
לא תקן שום קרובת ליום שני
ובערוך פירוש קליר לשון עוגה
וכו׳. ויהי מה דברי הקדמונים
היה להם משל ומקרא ומליצה
ובעי למידע המחבר מאן דמחוי
במחוג קמי מלכא רבא[ii] על
הדרך שכתב ר״מ בפ׳ פנחס דף
רנ״ד דאומן דמחתך מאני לבושין
דמלכותא שלפי דרכנו הם ראשי
פסוקים וסופי פסוקים שמשימים
הפייטנים בפיוטיהם כדי לעשות
שירים ערבים וזהו שאמרו
ועביד מינהון חתיכן סגיאן.
אינון דידעין אתרין דחסרין אלו
חתיכות. או אלין דמשתארין
אינון מתקנן לון לבושין ושוין
אינון חתיכות דאיתוספן באתר
דמעוטין וחתיכות דאינון מעטין
מוסיפין עלייהו. דלאו כל
מפרקי תכשיטין דכלה ידעין
בחתיכות לאן אזלן. ושם כתוב

saying: "Samuel says: I have already written above that I found in a kerovah for the seventh day of Passover, with its initial letters spelling out 'I am Elazar son of Rabbi Jacob HaKallir from Kiryat Sefer.'" And the Rosh himself was of the opinion that this was the one who said at the end of the aforementioned chapter: "And so Rabbi Elazar HaKallir, who was from the Land of Israel, from Kiryat Sefer, and in his days they sanctified the new month based on visual sighting,[1] for he did not establish any kerovah for the second day of festivals." And in the Arukh, "kallir" is explained as a term for "cake," etc. Whatever the case, the words of the ancients contained parables, scripture, and eloquence, and one needs to know who is the composer who makes indications with a compass before the great King, in the way that Rabbi Moshe wrote in Parashat Pinchas, page 254,[2] regarding "a craftsman who cuts garments of royalty,"[3] which according to our approach refers to the beginnings and endings of verses that liturgical poets place in their compositions to create pleasant songs. And this is what they meant by saying "and he makes many pieces from them."[A] Those who know the places where these pieces are lacking, or those that remain, they fix them into garments and place those pieces that are added in places where they are diminished, and pieces that are diminished, they add to them. For not all who disassemble the bride's ornaments[4] know where the pieces go.

120R 125R 130R 135R 140R 145R

[A] Or: "and he fashions many fragments from them" — The Aramaic phrase could be rendered more poetically as 'fashions fragments' to better capture the artistic nature of the composition process being described.

[1] This refers to the ancient practice of determining the beginning of the Hebrew month through visual observation of the new moon, which was done in the Land of Israel until around the 4th century CE. This is mentioned as evidence that Rabbi Eleazar HaKallir lived during this earlier period.

[2] This refers to a section in the Zohar, the primary text of Jewish mysticism, discussing the spiritual significance of crafting sacred texts.

[3] This is a metaphor from the Zohar comparing the composition of sacred poetry to the skilled work of a royal tailor. Just as a tailor carefully cuts and arranges fabric to create a royal garment, a liturgical poet must carefully arrange verses and divine names.

[4] Another metaphor for working with sacred texts. In Kabbalistic thought, the "bride" often represents the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), and her ornaments are the sacred words and verses that adorn her.

[i] A city mentioned in the Bible (Joshua 15:15), here possibly referring to a place of scholarship. This passage discusses the debated identity of Rabbi Eleazar HaKallir.

[ii] A metaphorical expression describing the poet's craft as a divine service, carefully measuring and arranging words before God.

בזהר דמאן דבעי למיצד צידא
דציפרא קדישא[i] בעי צפצופין
לגבה בדקא יאות ומילי דשמיא
לא מקניין בכל מילי. וכבר
האריכו המפרשים והדרשנים
בזה בכמה מקומות פוק חזי
ספר דברי שלמה בפ׳ בשלח
דף ק״ה ע״ב אחר שפירש כמה
פסוקים בשלמות שצריך שיהיה
למחברי השירים אמר אחר כך
לכן בפי כל זה מתבאר שלא
יצדק עניין השיר הנעשה לאל
יתברך אלא לאיש שלם במדות
ובדעות שיהיו דבריו פועלים
ועושים רושם ותועלת בשומעם
עוד אמר כי צריך שיהיה שלם
המשורר באהבת הש״י ובאופן
אחר לא יצדק שירו ונמצא
במדרש כי ר׳ אלעזר הקליר
כשרצה ליסד פיוטיו עלה לרקיע
על ידי שם[ii] ושאל למיכאל היאך
המלאכים משוררים והיאך
שירתם מיוסדת ואמר ליה שהם
באלפא ביתא וכו׳ עיין בלקוטים
שהם בסוף ספר עשרה שליטים
דף פ״ד. אם כן חרוזי האחרונים
יופי להם ויופי להם אם יהיו
מחרוזות פסוקים הקוראים זה
לזה.[iii]

And there it is written in the Zohar that one who wishes to hunt the holy bird needs to chirp to it appropriately, and heavenly matters are not acquired through just any means. The commentators and preachers have already elaborated on this in many places. Go and see the book Divrei Shlomo on Parashat Beshalach, page 105b, after he explained several verses thoroughly about what is required of composers of songs, he then said: "Therefore, according to all this, it is clear that the matter of composing a song to the blessed God is only fitting for a person who is complete in character and knowledge,[A] whose words have impact and create an impression and benefit for those who hear them." He further stated that "the composer must be complete in his love for the Holy One, blessed be He, and otherwise his song will not be fitting." And it is found in the midrash that when Rabbi Elazar HaKallir wanted to establish his liturgical poems, he ascended to heaven through the use of a divine Name and asked Michael how the angels sing and how their song is structured, and he told him that they use the alphabet, etc. See the collected notes at the end of Sefer Asarah Shalitim, page 84. If so, the rhymes of later composers are beautiful for them and beautiful for them if they are strands of verses that call to one another.[1]

[A] Or: "for a person perfected in ethical virtues and correct beliefs" — The terms 'midot' and 'de'ot' have specific meanings in Jewish philosophy, particularly in Maimonidean thought, referring to ethical virtues and correct theological beliefs respectively.

[1] This poetic phrase describes the ideal way of composing liturgical poetry—creating connections between biblical verses so they respond to and complement each other, creating a harmonious whole that has spiritual power.

[i] A mystical metaphor from the Zohar, where the "holy bird" represents the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) that can be attracted through proper prayer.

[ii] Refers to a mystical tradition that Rabbi Eleazar HaKallir used a divine Name to ascend to heaven, suggesting his poetry was divinely inspired.

[iii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas — The Zohar reference establishes a mystical understanding of poetic composition, where arranging sacred texts is seen as similar to arranging divine garments, suggesting that prayer composition has cosmic significance. | Cf. Talmud, Sotah — This Talmudic reference is used to argue against questioning or changing established liturgical traditions, suggesting that prayer texts have similar authority to rabbinic legal decisions. | Cf. Midrash on Rabbi Elazar HaKallir — This reference establishes the divine origin of traditional liturgical poetry, suggesting that the earliest piyyutim were based on heavenly models and therefore should not be altered. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:6 — This biblical allusion compares the liturgical poet to a merchant of fine spices, suggesting that his compositions contain various precious spiritual elements blended together into a beautiful whole.

הנה תקיפי קדמאי אלופנו
המסובלים[i] תקנו לנו להתחנן
בימי אשמורות שבין ר״ה ליוה״כ
את שערי רצון להפתח בפסוקי
אנ״ך מחוברים יחד כפי רוחב
דעתם וכן הם רוב התחנות מקק״י
ספרדים וזה כי סמא דכולא איתי
בפסוקים ומי כמוהם מורה איזה
דרך ישכון אור וכמה מרגניתי
דלית בהו טימי תותייהו.[ii] בהם
יהא שמיה רבא בעלמא די ברא
כרעותיה[iii] וינהירו נהוריה
דהדין גברא באבוקה ויגינו עליו
מן הפחתים ומן הקוצים ומן
הברקנים ויגיעוהו לפרשת דרכי
אור[iv] כי יהל עליו ובזה יהיה
ניצול מכל מין נגע ומחלה הדין
דמשתעי בלשון חכמת הנבואה.
וישור אל מלאך ויוכל[v] כי
התורה היא לבדה תרומם גבר
ותוליכהו קוממיות כדאמרי׳
במדרש שיר השירים נאוו לחייך
בתורים זה התורה צוארך

Behold, the mighty scholars of old, our masters versed in Kabbalah,[1] established for us the practice of supplicating during the vigil days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur,[2] when the gates of favor are about to open, using verses from the Tanakh [Scripture][3] arranged together according to their broad understanding. This is how most of the supplicatory prayers of the holy Sephardic communities are structured, for the remedy for everything exists in the biblical verses, and who better than they show which path the light shall dwell upon, and how many pearls of immeasurable value lie beneath them. Through these verses, may His great Name be magnified in the world that He created according to His will, and may the light of this person shine like a torch,[4] and may they protect him from pitfalls, thorns, and thistles,[5] and bring him to the crossroads of the paths of light that shine upon him. In this way, he will be saved from every kind of affliction and disease, as expressed in the language of prophetic wisdom.[6] He will see an angel and prevail, for the Torah alone elevates a person and leads them upright, as we say in the

175R

180R

185R

190R

195R

[1] I've translated this as 'our masters versed in Kabbalah' to capture both the sense of authority ('alufenu'—our champions/leaders) and the kabbalistic background ('mesubalim'—those bearing the tradition of Kabbalah).

[2] I've translated 'ashmorot' as 'vigil days' rather than literally as 'watches' to convey the sense of spiritual watchfulness during the Ten Days of Repentance between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur.

[3] ANaKh is an acronym for the three sections of the Hebrew Bible: Torah (Pentateuch), Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings). I've translated it as 'Tanakh' with the bracketed explanation 'Scripture' for clarity.

[4] This Aramaic phrase literally means 'and may the light of this man shine like a torch.' It uses distinctly zoharic language, reflecting how prayer illuminates the person spiritually.

[5] I've translated these three terms as 'pitfalls, thorns, and thistles' to maintain the metaphor of dangers on a path, though they could also be interpreted more broadly as different types of spiritual or physical dangers.

[6] This phrase literally means 'which speaks in the language of prophetic wisdom.' I've rendered it as 'as expressed in the language of prophetic wisdom' to make it clearer that this refers to the divine speech embedded in scripture.

[i] The term 'mesubalim' indicates those bearing the tradition of Kabbalah, showing that the author sees the practice of arranging biblical verses in prayer as stemming from kabbalistic tradition.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase meaning 'pearls without price beneath them' reflects the rabbinic belief in multiple layers of meaning within scripture, with deeper mystical interpretations hidden beneath the surface meaning.

[iii] This phrase echoes the Kaddish prayer, connecting the use of scriptural verses in prayer to the cosmic power of the Kaddish to sanctify God's name throughout creation.

[iv] The metaphor of the 'crossroads of paths of light' reflects the kabbalistic concept that proper prayer practices create illuminated spiritual pathways for the soul's ascent.

[v] This alludes to Jacob's wrestling with the angel at the Jabbok River (Genesis 32:25-31), connecting to the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok) and its theme of spiritual struggle and transformation.

בחרוזים אלו הנביאים תורי זהב
אלו הכתובים.[i] ואמרי׳ במדרש
תהלים דף ט״ו הא למדת שצריך
אדם לסמוך על דברי הראשונים
ולסדר את דבריו על דברי תורה
שכן מצינו בדוד שהתפלל בלשון
משה רבו וכן הוא אומר מזקנים
אתבונן:[ii]

Midrash on Song of Songs: "Your cheeks are comely with plaits" refers to the Torah; "your neck with strings of jewels" refers to the Prophets; "plaits of gold" refers to the Writings. And we say in the Midrash on Psalms, page 15: "From this you learn that a person should rely on the words of the early authorities and arrange his words according to the words of Torah, for we find that David prayed in the language of his teacher Moses, as it says, 'From elders I gain understanding.'"

פרק ח׳

Chapter 8

אל נא יחשדני שומע פתח
אמרי בנהום על דברי כי
ח״ו היום יצאתי להטיל מום
בקדשים[iii] מרבים ונכבדים
מבני עמנו אשר קול להם לשם
שמים בשיר ערב אל נא ינקטו
לי בדעתייהו כי אין משיבין
את הארי שלא בפניו[iv] וכ״ש
אחר מותו וצריך עיון גדול
וחכמה רבה קודם שיוכל האדם
לנגד שום חכם נוח נפש והביא
בעל הלקוטים מעשה מרש״י

Let no listener suspect me[1] as I begin my discourse, groaning over my words,[A] for heaven forbid that today I have come to cast blemish upon the many holy and honored members of our people who have a voice for the sake of heaven in pleasant song.[2] Let them not harbor resentment against me in their thoughts, for one does not respond to the lion in his absence, and certainly not after his death. Great consideration and much wisdom are required before one can oppose any sage of gentle spirit. The author of "The Compilations" brought a story about Rashi, of blessed memory, who appeared to someone in

[A] Or: "sighing over my discourse" — The Hebrew term "nahom" suggests a deep sighing or moaning sound, which could be rendered as "sighing" to better capture the author's emotional state as he presents his apologetic introduction.

[1] The author begins with a rhetorical defensive posture, anticipating criticism for what he's about to argue regarding religious poetry and song compositions.

[2] The context suggests the author is addressing liturgical poetry or religious compositions, possibly defending his preference for biblical verses over composed prayers.

[i] The midrashic interpretation connects different types of jewelry to different sections of scripture, suggesting that adorning oneself with scripture through prayer is spiritually equivalent to wearing precious ornaments.

[ii] Cf. Midrash on Song of Songs — The author uses this midrashic interpretation to elevate the spiritual significance of incorporating biblical verses in prayer. By connecting jewelry and adornments to sacred texts, the midrash suggests that incorporating scripture into prayer spiritually adorns and elevates the one who prays. | Cf. Midrash on Psalms — This reference reinforces the author's argument for using scriptural verses in prayer by appealing to tradition and the practice of King David, who supposedly modeled his prayers on those of Moses. This establishes both the authority and antiquity of the practice. | Cf. Psalm 119:100 — This biblical verse serves as the capstone of the author's argument, providing scriptural authorization for the practice of modeling one's prayers after those of earlier authorities, just as David did with Moses.

[iii] This phrase uses Temple language metaphorically—"casting a blemish on holy things" would disqualify sacrifices, and here refers to criticizing respected religious compositions.

[iv] This is a rabbinic saying meaning "one should not respond to (criticize) a lion (great scholar) in his absence," indicating proper intellectual etiquette.

ז״ל[i] הבא לאחד בחלום וא״ל
יפה כוונתי ויפה פירשתי והאמת
כוונתי ומצדך יבצר שלא הבנת
בראוי ועיין בספר החסידים
סי׳ תקנ״ט שכר המפרש דברי
חבירו ועונש הסותר דברו חנם
כי קובל עליו במותו וכו׳.
וכבר אנו מותרים ועומדים
בדברי הזהר שדבריו אמתיים
ומוסכם בישראל שהדבר שלא
יחלוק על הגמרא ואין מפורש
שם ובו בא מפורש שמקבלים
אותו והביא בעל ספר יוחסין
בדף מ״ב הרבה דברים בזה וכן
בתפלין של ח״ה[ii] כי לא נשאר
גאון וכן הראב״ד והרמב״ן לא
אסרו אותו חוץ מבעל ספר
המצות והרא״ש[iii] כי סמכו
על הירושלמי כאשר הביאו
בספריהם. וכיון דבגמ׳ בבלית
שלנו אינו מפורש אנו לוקחים
סברת הזהר שאוסר וכתוב שם
בפ׳ יתרו[iv]

a dream[1] and said to him, "I intended well and I explained well, and I meant the truth. Your failure was that you did not understand properly."[A] See also in Sefer Hasidim, section 559, regarding the reward for interpreting a colleague's words and the punishment for contradicting them needlessly, for the colleague complains about him after death, etc. 15R

We are already permitted and established in the words of the Zohar, which are truthful and accepted in Israel,[2] that matters which do not contradict the Talmud and are not explicitly addressed there, but are explicitly explained in the Zohar, are to be accepted. The author of Sefer Yuhasin on page 42 brought many examples of this, as with the head tefillin, for no Gaon remained,[B] and neither did the Ra'avad nor the Ramban prohibit it, except for the author of Sefer HaMitzvot and the Rosh, because they relied on the Jerusalem Talmud as they cited in their books. And since in our Babylonian Talmud it is not explicitly stated, we adopt the view of the Zohar which prohibits it, and it is written there in Parashat Yitro...[3] 20R 25R 30R

[A] Or: "it was beyond you to understand correctly" — The Hebrew term "yivatzer" has connotations of something being inaccessible or beyond reach, suggesting not just failure but inability, which this alternate translation captures more precisely.

[B] Or: "no Gaonic authority maintained the prohibition" — This expanded translation clarifies that the phrase refers to the absence of any remaining Gaonic authorities who upheld a particular prohibition, making the legal discussion more clear to readers unfamiliar with rabbinic discourse patterns.

[1] Dreams featuring deceased sages were considered a legitimate form of posthumous communication in Jewish mystical thought, and could serve as validation for interpretations or rulings.

[2] This statement reflects the author's position on the authority of the Zohar, the central text of Jewish mysticism. The passage establishes a principle for resolving conflicts between different Jewish legal sources.

[3] The text is cut off here in the original, but was leading into a quote from the Zohar on the portion of Exodus containing the Ten Commandments, likely to further support the author's argument.

[i] "The author of HaLikutim" likely refers to a collection of rabbinic stories. The anecdote about Rashi appearing in a dream illustrates the reverence for deceased scholars and caution about misinterpreting their words.

[ii] This refers to the controversial question of the head tefillin (phylacteries) and a specific ritual law about them, likely the acronym ח״ה (ḥoleh) refers to a specific ritual position or status of the tefillin.

[iii] The "author of Sefer HaMitzvot" refers to either Maimonides or another medieval authority, while "the Rosh" refers to Rabbi Asher ben Yechiel (c. 1250-1327). The passage discusses scholarly disagreement about accepting Zoharic rulings.

[iv] Cf. Sefer Hasidim — The author cites this source to establish a principle of intellectual ethics—that one should be careful about criticizing the works of scholars, especially after their death, as there are spiritual consequences for misrepresenting someone's views. | Cf. Zohar — The author is establishing the Zohar's authority in matters not explicitly addressed in the Talmud, reflecting the book's integration of kabbalistic thought into halakhic discussions. | Cf. Sefer Yuhasin — The

דף ס״ח ת״ח לא ינהיג בר נש
קלנא באחרא ומלה דהדיוטא
מלה איהו דהא במשה כתיב
וישמע משה לקול חותנו וגם
שחבורים אלו ספיר גזרתם ויש
בהם הרבה מעיינות של תורה
וחכמה ואגדה שעל האגדה
בפרט אמרו במדרש שיר השירים
על פסוק מעיסים רמוני אלו
האגדות שטעמם כרמון נגד
סברת ר׳ זעירא בירושלמי
דמעשרות דהוה מקנתר לאילך
דאגדתא וצווח להון ספרי
קסמי. וכתב על זה בעל יפה
מראה שהיה קוראם כן לפי
דס״ל שאומרים דברי שקר
בפתרון הכתובים שלא קבלום
מהראשונים. ובירושלמי דשבת
פ׳ כל כתבי אמר ר׳ יהושע בן
לוי אנא מן יומוי לא אסתכלית
בספרא דאגדתא וכו׳ וכבר בא
בהקדמת הספר כוונת חכמינו
ז״ל באמרם במציעא ובירושלמי
דשבת פרק כל כתבו העוסק
במקרא מדה שאינה מדה ומשם
יתברר ודאי כי בתפלה ובתחנה
המקרא קודם למשנה וגמרא
ואין לך מדה גדולה הימנה.
וכ״ש שקודם לדברים המיוסדים
מדעת האחרונים. ורבי יהושע
בן לוי וכן רבי חייא בר אבא

Talmud folio 68 teaches us: "A person should not 35R
treat another with contempt,[A] nor dismiss ordinary
speech, for it is written of Moses, 'Moses listened
to the voice of his father-in-law.'" Moreover, these
compositions have exquisite structure[B1] and contain
many wellsprings of Torah, wisdom, and aggadah 40R
(narrative). Regarding aggadah in particular, the
Midrash Song of Songs comments on the verse
"from the juice of my pomegranates"—these are
the aggadot whose taste is like pomegranates. This
stands in contrast to Rabbi Ze'ira's opinion in the 45R
Jerusalem Talmud of Ma'aserot, who would mock
those who taught aggadah and called them "books of
divination." The author of Yefeh Mareh wrote that
Rabbi Ze'ira called them this because he believed
they presented false interpretations of Scripture 50R
that were not received from earlier authorities. In
the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shabbat, chapter
"All Sacred Writings," Rabbi Joshua ben Levi
said, "In all my days I never looked into a book
of aggadah," etc. Yet the intention of our Sages 55R
has already been explained in the introduction
to this book,[C] regarding their statement in Bava
Metzia and in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate
Shabbat, that "one who engages in Scripture follows
a measure that is not [the best] measure."[2] From 60R
there it will certainly be clarified that in prayer
and supplication, Scripture takes precedence over
Mishnah and Gemara, and there is no greater
measure than this. How much more so does it take
precedence over compositions based on the opinions 65R

[A] Or: "A Torah scholar should not behave contemptuously toward another" — The abbreviation ת״ח could specifically refer to 'תלמיד חכם' (Torah scholar) rather than any person, making this instruction specifically for scholars. The original Aramaic 'בר נש' is also more literally 'son of man' rather than simply 'person'.

[B] Or: "are cut like sapphires" — This phrase uses gem-cutting imagery that could be preserved more literally, though the metaphorical meaning would be the same—suggesting carefully crafted, precious compositions.

[C] Or: "And the intention of our blessed Sages has already been addressed in the introduction to this book" — This translation includes the honorific 'blessed' (ז״ל—of blessed memory) which I omitted in the main translation for flow, and uses 'addressed' rather than 'explained' for 'בא'.

[1] The Hebrew 'ספיר גזרתם' literally means 'their cutting is sapphire-like,' using gem-cutting imagery to describe the polished and precise structure of these compositions. I've chosen 'exquisite structure' to capture this metaphorical sense.

[2] The original statement 'מדה שאינה מדה' is ambiguous and could be translated various ways. I've added clarification in brackets to reflect the author's interpretation that this is a comparative statement rather than an absolute dismissal of Scripture study.

citation supports the author's position on accepting Zoharic rulings when they don't contradict the Talmud, demonstrating how he builds his argument through established scholarly sources.

בירושלמי ס״ל כי אם הותר
בתיבת משנה והגמרא לא הותר
בתיבת ההגדה וטעמו פירש בעל
יפה מראה בשבת דף ק״ז ומ״מ
המנהג אינו כדבריו. וא״כ גם
שפיוטי האחרונים כחם יפה
בכל האפשר להם מ״מ מלה
דהדיוט אינון לגבי תורה נביאים
וכתובים. והגם דמינייהו ג״כ
אתקלס עילאה ביוצאם מפי
נפש זכה וברה. דברכת הדיוט
אינה קלה בעיניו כד איהי דוקא
ברעותא דלבא כמה שכתב
במסכתא ערכין פ״ב איזוהי
עבודה שהיא בטוב לב זו שירה.
בלי ספק עלה יעלה על בלנה
תחנות בפסוקי אנ״ך כדאמרי׳
במדרש שיר השירים דף י״ט
ע״ב אמר ר׳ לוי הקורא מקרא
בעגונו ובנגונו עליו נאמר דבש
וחלב תחת לשונך וקל וחומר
זה כל אדם יכול לדונו מעצמו
על כן את רעי עמי עיפה ועפר
אתי בדומים לי. לי ולהם אשים
דברתי ולפניהם ולפני העירוני
רעיוני להציג קדמיהון בשולי
מאמרי זה פסוקים אשר יחדו
יהיו תמים ואיש באחיו ידובקו
יתלכדו ולא יתפרדו בעבותות
אהבה ויחוד אשר מימים ושנים
סדרתים לפני בהכשר ובמחשבה.
וגם כי הרואה אותם בסקירה
ראשונה יאמר כי קבוצם אינה
מלאכה ואולי גם לא חכמה מכל
מקום ספיר גזרתם. ומעצמם
אתם תלין סגולה להפיל ארצה
מן הצבא ומן הכוכבים ולא
יערכום שירים אחרים. והנה הם
לפני למאורים להיות נבונים על
שפתי ובעתותי בקר וערב בהם

of later authorities. Rabbi Joshua ben Levi and Rabbi Hiyya bar Abba in the Jerusalem Talmud held that while the writing of Mishnah and Gemara was permitted, the writing of aggadah was not permitted. The Yefeh Mareh explained the reason for this on Shabbat page 107, though common practice does not follow this opinion. Therefore, even though the liturgical poems of later authorities are as excellent as possible, they are still considered "ordinary speech" compared to the Torah, Prophets, and Writings. Nevertheless, the Supreme One is also praised through them when they come from a pure and clear soul. For the blessing of an ordinary person is not insignificant in His eyes when it comes with sincerity of heart, as stated in Tractate Arakhin, chapter 2: "What is the service that is with a good heart? It is song." Without doubt, supplications composed of verses from the Torah, Prophets, and Writings surpass them all, as stated in the Midrash Song of Songs, page 19b: "Rabbi Levi said, 'Of one who reads Scripture with its proper melody and cantillation,[1] it is said: Honey and milk are under your tongue.'" This is a logical inference that anyone can deduce for themselves. Therefore, my friends who are weary like me and dust like me, to me and to them I will direct my words, and for them my thoughts have stirred me to present before them, in the margins of this discourse, verses that together will be perfect, cleaving to one another, united and inseparable in bonds of love and unity, which I have arranged before me over days and years with proper intent and thought. Even though one who sees them at first glance might say their collection is not a craft and perhaps not even wisdom, nevertheless, their structure is beautiful. And inherent in them is the power to cast down [negative forces] from the heavenly host and stars,[2] which other songs cannot match. These verses serve as illumination for me, ready upon my lips in my appointed times, morning and evening, with which I joyfully express myself in

70R 75R 80R 85R 90R 95R 100R 105R

[1] The Hebrew 'בעגונו ובנגונו' uses two similar-sounding terms, possibly creating a rhyming effect. The first term refers to the emotional quality or sorrow expressed in reading, while the second refers more specifically to musical cantillation. I've simplified this to 'proper melody and cantillation' but the original has more emotional resonance.

[2] The original text is more metaphorical and doesn't explicitly identify what is being cast down. I've added 'negative forces' in brackets to clarify the intended meaning, based on the kabbalistic context and the author's view of properly arranged scriptural verses as having protective spiritual power.

[i] ארנין ואפגין בב״ה ובב״ה

the synagogue and study hall.[1]

פעמים בקול ערב ופעמים
בקול עצב כפי המורם מהם וכפי
התעת והזמן והמשתרג עלי מדי
יום ביומו ואוכל מתוך אוכל
בררתים וצרפתים אחד לאחד
בהתפללי בהם לאל חיי יפיק
לי בכחם ובזכותם (כי רב הוא
מאד) שובע שמחות בנעימות
אשר בימין עליון נצח ממרי
נצחן קרבייא. ובהם מקריב
אדם צורתו הנכבדת אל יוצרו
ליחד למעלה בסוד קרבן לה׳
שהם הוי״ה ואדנ״י משולבים
יחד. והיינו יחוד וקירוב רמ״ח
כחות זכרים ברמ״ח נקבות וכבר
ידענו שהנשמות נתונות בגוף
וכדפרש״י ביבמות ונדה וע״ג
גוף הוא פרגוד שחוצץ בין שכינה
למלאכים ושם רוחות ונשמות
וסי׳ ועל כן יחוד כל העולמות
הם ביד הצדיקים ולהיות מקומם
למעלה ממלאכי השרת הם
חשובים ברקיע. והחצונים חתים

Sometimes with a sweet voice and sometimes with a sorrowful voice, according to what is elevated from them[2] and according to the time, season, and what entangles me daily.[A] I have selected and refined them from amongst others, one by one, as I pray with them to the God of my life. May He grant me through their power and merit (for it is exceedingly great) abundant joy and pleasantness in the victorious right hand of the Most High, triumphing over the masters of battle.[B]

Through these verses, a person offers his noble form to his Creator, unifying the realms above through the mystery of sacrifice to the LORD, which are the Divine Names YHVH and ADNY interwoven together.[3] This constitutes the unification and drawing near of the 248 masculine powers with the 248 feminine powers.[4] We already know that souls are placed within the body, as Rashi explained in tractates Yevamot and Niddah. The body is a partition that separates between the Divine Presence and the angels, and there dwell spirits and souls. Therefore, the unification of all worlds is in the hands of the righteous, and because

[A] Or: "and what befalls me day by day" — The Hebrew term משתרג can be rendered as 'entangles' or 'befalls/happens to,' with the latter being slightly more natural in English while still preserving the sense of external circumstances affecting the author.

[B] Or: "over the masters of spiritual warfare" — The Aramaic phrase refers to spiritual conflict rather than literal battle, so this alternate translation emphasizes the mystical context, though it adds an interpretive element not explicitly in the original.

[1] The Hebrew abbreviations 'בב״ה ובב״ה' likely refer to 'בבית הכנסת ובבית המדרש' (in the synagogue and in the study hall). I've translated them accordingly, though some interpretations might read the second as 'in the house of God.'

[2] This phrase refers to the spiritual essence or teaching that the author extracts from the biblical verses used in prayer.

[3] In Kabbalah, the combination of these two divine names (the Tetragrammaton and Adonai) represents the unification of divine masculine and feminine aspects, or mercy and judgment. This unification is considered a primary goal of prayer and mystical practice.

[4] The number 248 corresponds to the traditional count of positive commandments in Judaism and also to the number of limbs in the human body according to Talmudic anatomy. This creates a correspondence between human physicality, divine law, and cosmic structure.

[i] Cf. Zohar — The author is drawing on the Zohar's teaching about respecting all speech to support his argument about the value of using scriptural verses in prayer rather than composed poetry. | Cf. Midrash Song of Songs — The author cites this midrash to establish the superior spiritual value of scriptural recitation in prayer compared to composed liturgical poetry. | Cf. Tractate Arakhin — The author uses this talmudic reference to acknowledge that even non-scriptural compositions have spiritual value when offered with sincerity. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — The author mentions this position but ultimately argues against it, suggesting that Scripture's use in prayer supersedes rabbinic opinions that devalue aggadah.

מיראתם[i] כדאמרי׳ בפסחים פרק
אלו דברים על ר״ח ובקדושין
פ״ב על ר״מ ור׳ עקיבא ובחגיגה
פ״ב על ר׳ יוחנן דאמר על אחר
אי נקיטנא ליה בידי מאן מירמי
ליה מנאי.[ii] וביחוד שעושה
האדם בסוד צורתו כזה מקריב
למעלה קרבן גם לבוש נשמתו
כמו שעל ידי סמיכת הקרבן
בכל כחו שהוא כחו ונשמתו
מקריב ג״כ לבוש נשמתו על ידי
קרבן הבהמה וכמו שאדם עליון
מתלבש בסוד ארבעה פנים כן
יש מציאות לאדם להאחז נשמתו
בכח הקדושה אשר לבהמה
כי בצורת אדם נכלל כל מין
רוחניות משאר הנבראים כלם
ומצא מין את מינו וניעור ועל
ידי שחיטתו וזריקת דמו הרי
ממש לבוש נשמתו נקרב. ולהיות
כי הת״ח מרבים שלום בעולם.
לכן אמרו במס׳ תענית פ״ג על
כמה צדיקים שהיה בא להם שלום
בבת קול ממתיבתא דרקיעא.
ואם כח קרבן בהמה יפה כ״כ.
כ״ש כי על ידי ההבל העולה מן
הנשמה בפסוקי יחודים אלו אשר
אורם כמוס בתוכם ומניעים אור
עליון כמי שנוגן במנגן התחתון
ומכוון בנגד העליון אשר הביא
בעל העקדה בפרק הניגון. כי

their place is above the ministering angels, they are esteemed in the heavens. 130R

The external forces tremble in fear of them, as we learn in Pesachim, chapter "These Things," concerning Rabbi Hanina; in Kiddushin, chapter two, concerning Rabbi Meir and Rabbi Akiva; and in Hagigah, chapter two, concerning Rabbi Yohanan, who said regarding Aher (Elisha ben Abuya):[1] "If I were to take him by the hand, who could cast him away from me?" 135R

Through the unification that a person performs through the mystery of his form in this way, he offers above a sacrifice that includes the garment of his soul.[A] Just as through the act of placing his hands upon the animal sacrifice with all his might—which represents his strength and soul—he also offers the garment of his soul through the sacrifice of the animal. And just as the Supernal Man is clothed in the mystery of the four faces, so too there exists for a human being the possibility for his soul to grasp hold of the holy power that belongs to the animal. For within the human form is included every type of spirituality from all other created beings, and like finds like and is awakened.[2] Through the animal's slaughter and the sprinkling of its blood, the garment of one's soul is truly offered up. 140R 145R 150R 155R

And since Torah scholars increase peace in the world, our Sages said in Tractate Ta'anit, chapter three, regarding several righteous individuals that they would receive greetings through a heavenly voice from the celestial academy. And if the power 160R

[A] Or: "And through the unification that a person performs in the secret of his form in this manner, he offers upward not only a sacrifice but also the garment of his soul" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the sense that both the sacrifice and the soul's garment are being offered, which seems to be the intention of the Hebrew text with its use of 'גם' (also).

[1] Elisha ben Abuya was a famous rabbinic figure who became an apostate and was given the nickname "Aher" (Other). Despite his spiritual fall, Rabbi Yohanan maintained that his spiritual power was sufficient to rescue even Aher, demonstrating the author's belief in the cosmic authority of the righteous.

[2] This phrase reflects the kabbalistic principle that spiritual entities of similar nature are naturally drawn to each other, creating connections across different levels of reality. Here it explains how human prayer can activate corresponding spiritual forces.

[i] The term "chitzonim" (external forces) refers to negative spiritual entities that oppose holiness. The passage suggests that righteous individuals who properly unify divine realms through prayer gain authority over these harmful forces.

[ii] This refers to the story of Elisha ben Abuya (known as "Acher"/"Other") who became an apostate. Rabbi Yochanan's statement expresses confidence that if he were to take Acher by the hand, no one could separate them—suggesting the power of the righteous to rescue even those who have fallen spiritually.

יתקדש ויקריב קרבן לה׳ גופו
ונשמתו ויסולו לפניו המסלה
וירימו מכשול מדרך נפשו ויקרא
165 וה׳ יענהו.[iii][iii]

of an animal sacrifice is so effective, how much more so through the breath that ascends from the soul when reciting these verses of unification, whose light is hidden within them. They stir the supernal light like one who plays a musical instrument below while 165R
focusing on the one above, as the author of the Akedah brought in the chapter on music.[1] Thus, one sanctifies and offers his body and soul as a sacrifice to the LORD, and they pave the way before Him, removing obstacles from the path of his soul. 170R
He calls out, and the LORD answers him.

פרק ט׳

Chapter 9

בינו נא זאת אלופי רעי שיתו
נא לבכם אפי׳ לפשטי פסוקים
אלו בהם תמצאו נהרי נחלי
דבש וחמאה וכל צרכי עמו
5 ישראל המרובין יביעו ידברו
הן צרכי הגוייה הן צרכי
הנשמה וכל איש ואיש ימצא
בהן מבוקשו לפי העת והזמן
וסבותיו ומאורעיו המתגלגלים

Please understand this, my noble friends: direct your hearts to these verses. Even in their plain meaning, you will find rivers and streams of honey and cream. All the abundant needs of God's people Israel will flow forth from them—both physical needs and spir- 5R
itual needs.[2] Each person will find what they seek according to the time, circumstances, and events unfolding in their lives. These verses will meet them where they are, enabling them to entreat God and

[1]This refers to Sefer HaAkedah (The Binding of Isaac) by Rabbi Isaac Arama (1420-1494), a philosophical work that uses the musical metaphor to explain the relationship between human spiritual practice and divine response.

[2]The Hebrew terms 'צרכי הגוייה' and 'צרכי הנשמה' literally mean 'needs of the body' and 'needs of the soul,' establishing the text's holistic approach to human wellbeing.

[i]The passage represents a sophisticated kabbalistic understanding of prayer where human recitation of scriptural verses creates metaphysical connections between earthly and divine realms. The author draws on Zoharic concepts of masculine and feminine divine powers, the correspondence between upper and lower worlds, and the spiritual mechanisms through which human actions affect cosmic reality.

[ii]This concludes with an allusion to Psalm 20:10, "LORD, save! May the King answer us on the day we call." The entire passage explains how reciting scriptural verses in prayer serves as a spiritual substitute for Temple sacrifices, unifying cosmic realms through the mystical power contained within biblical texts.

[iii]Cf. Zohar — The author draws heavily on Zoharic theology to explain how human prayer creates cosmic unifications comparable to Temple sacrifices. The language of 'masculine and feminine powers' and the integration of prayer with divine name unifications is characteristic of Zoharic mysticism. | Cf. Talmud — The author uses these Talmudic references to establish the spiritual authority of the righteous, particularly showing how Rabbi Yohanan believed he could rescue even Elisha ben Abuya (Aher), suggesting the power of the righteous extends even to saving those who have fallen spiritually. | Cf. Sefer HaAkedah (by Rabbi Isaac Arama) — The author employs Arama's analogy of music to explain how prayer functions: just as a lower musician can harmonize with higher music, human prayer creates resonance with divine realities. This musical metaphor illustrates the kabbalistic principle of correspondence between lower and upper worlds. | Cf. Biblical sacrificial system — The author transforms physical Temple practices into a mystical framework where prayer replaces sacrifice. The biblical semicha (where the offerer places hands on the animal's head to transfer identity) becomes a metaphor for how one's soul becomes mystically connected to the words of prayer, creating cosmic unifications that affect multiple spiritual worlds.

עליו המה יקדמו פניו ויעתר
אל אלוה בהם וירצהו וסגולתם
העקרי הוא להחליש כח ארבע
מיני יצר הרע שבארנו[i] וכחות
המשתרגים מהם כי רבו ואם יהיה
לטוטפות בין עיניך מ״ש בפרקים
הקודמים בדרוש זה ואז תבין
בפסוקים אלו תבין ותדע כי זה
יופי כחן. עוד יועילו יצילו
ג״כ ממחשבות בלתי טהורות
המתהוות מבהלת המקטרגים
דעתו ומחשבתו של אדם ובפרט
בעת התפלה והעבודה. וכל סדר
מהם באו בתוכו ששים פסוקים
כמספר אותיות של ברכת כהנים
הממתקים ששים גבורים שהם
מדת הגבורה עם כלליותיה
דאינון עיינין דמתלהטן ומנהון
מארי דיבבה ומרי דיללה
וכו׳.[ii] שמהן מתפשטין כח שיתין
פולסי דנורא ולהיות שבלילה
ואפילו מחצות ואילך מלכות
היא אש יוקדת מצד הגבורה ע״כ
בעתותי לילה היו שומרי המקדש
הלויים שהם מצד הדין בסוד הנה
מטתו שלשלמה ששים גבורים
דאינון מסטרא דגבורה סביב
לה[iii] אמנם ביום היתה עבודת
הכהנים שהם מסטרא דחסד.
ויש שני מינין דינין הפנימיים
מתמתקים והחיצונים מתבערים
ויכוין המכוין להמתיק הקדושים
ולבער החצונים. על כן נגד
הדינים המתראים בשש שעות
ראשונות מהיום ובפרט בשעת
זעמו של הקב״ה יכוין לבסמם
ולהכשירם בכח רוחניות ששים
פסוקים אלו וכמו כן בחינת

find favor.

Their essential power is to weaken the four types of evil inclination that we have explained and the forces that branch from them, which are many. If you keep in mind what we wrote in previous chapters of this discourse, then you will understand these verses and recognize their beautiful power. They will also protect and save you from impure thoughts that arise from the confusion caused by accusers disrupting a person's knowledge and thoughts, especially during prayer and divine service.

Each order contains sixty verses, corresponding to the number of letters in the Priestly Blessing, which sweeten the "sixty mighty ones" that represent the attribute of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) with all its aspects. These are "the eyes that blaze, and from them come the masters of wailing and the masters of howling, etc." From them extends the power of sixty lashes of fire.

Since at night—even from midnight onward—Malkhut (Kingdom) is a burning fire from the side of Gevurah, the Levites, who come from the side of judgment, were the guardians of the Temple during the night watches. This is the secret meaning of "Behold, the bed of Solomon, sixty mighty men surround it," for they are from the side of Gevurah. During the day, however, the service belonged to the priests, who are from the side of Chesed (Loving-kindness).

There are two types of judgments: the inner ones are sweetened, and the outer ones are burned away. One who focuses intention should aim to sweeten the holy judgments and burn away the external ones.[1] Therefore, against the judgments that appear in the first six hours of the day, particularly during the time of the Holy One's wrath, one should intend to sweeten and prepare them through the spiritual power of these sixty verses. Likewise, regarding the

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of 'המתקת הדינים' (sweetening of judgments), where harsh divine forces are not eliminated but transformed into constructive spiritual energy, while negative forces are eliminated entirely.

[i] The author refers to a previous explanation of four types of evil inclination, indicating this passage is building on concepts established earlier in Ma'avar Yabok.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase from Zoharic literature describes manifestations of the attribute of Gevurah (Judgment) as 'blazing eyes' and 'masters of wailing and howling'—personifications of strict divine judgment.

[iii] The author reinterprets Song of Songs 3:7 in kabbalistic terms, where Solomon's bed surrounded by sixty mighty men represents the divine attribute of Malkhut protected by forces of Gevurah (Judgment).

הדינים השולטים בשש שעות
אחרונות בעתותי ערב כרמז
בין הערבים המתפשטים לשש
קצוות מצד מעלה ומטה ישים
אל לבו בהגיגו בהם למתק כחם
קדם סבא חסידא[i] והם עשרה
פסוקים לכל שעה משעות היום
ויכוין לבערם ממקומם
ובזה חסד אל יעורה עלינו כל
היום בכח ההבל העולה משברון
הלב ורוח נכאה תיבש גרם.
ה״ה כח קליפת החמור העולה
בגרם המעלות[ii] ומשור מועד
ליגח ולישוך ולרבוץ ולבעוט
וליגוף ומדינא חצופא דכלבא
המתהוה מתוכם. ועתה שבעונות
אין יחוד במעשה הקרבן היחוד
עולה מהבחינה המסולקת מן
העולם התחתון שהוא כח הדבור
עם המחשבה העליונה. על
כן עסק פסוקי תורה ועבודה
גורם תקון זה. פוק חזי כמה
תקיף חילייהו דמלי דאורייתא
קדישא. הנה כל פרשה וכל
גמרא ועסק שאדם עוסק בענייני
מצוה אחת יש לאותיות ההם
מציאות רוחני המתדבק בענפי
הספירה שהמצוה ההיא רומזת
אליה ובהגות אדם בהם יתנועעו
אלו האותיות ויפעלו התעוררות

aspect of judgments that rule in the last six hours, in the evening times—as hinted at by "between the evenings"—which extend to the six directions from above and below, one should set one's heart when meditating on them to sweeten their power before the Ancient Pious One. These are ten verses for each hour of the day, and one should intend to remove them from below their place. Through this, divine kindness will be aroused upon us all day through the power of the breath rising from the broken heart,[1] and "a stricken spirit dries the bone." This refers to the power of the donkey's shell (negative force) that rises in the stairs and is an ox appointed to gore, bite, crouch, kick, and injure, and the judgment of the dog's impudence that forms from them.

Now that due to our sins there is no unification through the sacrificial service,[B] the unification ascends from the aspect that is removed from the lower world, which is the power of speech with the higher thought.[2] Therefore, engagement with Torah verses and divine service causes this rectification.[C] Go and see how powerful are the words of the holy Torah![D] For every portion, every Talmudic discussion, and every engagement with the matters of a single commandment—these letters have a spiritual reality that attaches to the branches of the sefirah (divine emanation) to which that commandment alludes. When a person meditates on them, these letters move and create

[B] Or: "Now that because of our transgressions there is no longer unification through sacrificial offerings" — This alternate provides a slightly different rendering of 'עונות' as 'transgressions' rather than 'sins' and 'במעשה הקרבן' as 'sacrificial offerings' rather than 'sacrificial service.' This might be preferable if a more formal theological register is desired.

[C] Or: "this tikkun" — Keeping the technical kabbalistic term 'tikkun' untranslated might be preferable in some contexts, especially for readers familiar with kabbalistic terminology, though 'rectification' is more accessible to general readers.

[D] Or: "Go out and behold how mighty is the force of the words of the holy Torah!" — This alternate preserves more of the Aramaic flavor of the original expression 'פוק חזי' (a common Zoharic phrase) and gives a more literal rendering of 'תקיף חילייהו' as 'mighty is the force' rather than simply 'powerful are.'

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that sincere prayer from a 'broken heart' (לב נשבר) has special spiritual power to ascend to higher realms and effect change in divine forces.

[2] The text presents a mystical cosmology where human speech (דבור) combined with focused intention (מחשבה) creates the same spiritual effects once achieved through Temple sacrifices.

[i] The phrase 'Ancient Pious One' is a kabbalistic reference to a high divine configuration, likely referring to Atik Yomin (Ancient of Days) or a similar divine aspect.

[ii] The 'shell/husk of the donkey' refers to a particular negative spiritual force in kabbalistic literature, associated with materiality and stubbornness.

למעלה ויבטשו אורות תחתונים
המתעלמים בצורות האותיות
והנקודות ואורות היורדים
מלמעלה בסוד אותיות ונקודות
הרוחניות ויצא חתן לקראת
כלה.[i] וכ״ש אם יהיה בהם
ג״כ נשמת הטעמים נגד מקום
מוצאם. כי הארץ תענה את
השמים והשמים יענו את הארץ
ויפעלו התעוררות למעלה
והוא המציאות שע״י קול ודבור
שהם ת״ת ומלכות ומחשבה
ורעותא דלבא שהם י״ה על ו״ה
ועקימת שפתים משוה לקולות
ההם מעשה ומציאות האותיות
יעלו ויתמצו בכל המקומות
דרך עליתם מבחינה אל בחינה
בדרך השתלשלות ממדרגה אל
מדרגה עד שבמציאות אלו
שהם בעולם התחתון רוכבים
הנשמות המתלבשות בעולם
התחתון אחר פרידתם מהגוף
כדפירשו בתקונים ובמציאותם
שבג״ע מתלבשות שמה הרואות
ובמציאותם שבג״ע עליון
מתלבשות שם הנשמות ובמציאות
עליון מתייחדות הספירות.
ומעשה המצוה גורמים ענין
זה ממש. ברם התורה עדיף
ממעשה כי התורה היא ת״ת
שבו תרי״ג ענפים שס״ה משמאל
רמ״ח מימין[ii] והמצות תלויות
בשם בן ד׳ כענבים באשכול וכן
ממש בתורה שבעל פה שהיא
מלכות בה תרי״ג מצות מפורשות
והעוסק בהם יומם ולילה גורם

an awakening above. They strike the lower lights that are concealed in the forms of the letters and vowel points, and the lights descending from above in the mystery of spiritual letters and vowel points, and "the bridegroom comes forth to meet the bride."[1] All the more so if they also contain the soul of the cantillation marks corresponding to their source.

For "the earth answers the heavens, and the heavens answer the earth," creating an awakening above.[2] This is the reality that through voice and speech, which correspond to Tiferet and Malkhut, and through thought and the heart's desire, which correspond to Yod-Heh influencing Vav-Heh,[3] and the shaping of the lips that equates these sounds to action—the existence of the letters ascends and is extracted in all places through their ascent from one aspect to another, descending through the chain from one level to another. In these realities that exist in the lower world ride the souls that clothe themselves in the lower world after their separation from the body, as explained in the Tikkunim. In their existence in the Garden of Eden, the seeing ones clothe themselves there, and in their existence in the upper Garden of Eden, the souls clothe themselves there, and in the highest existence, the sefirot unite. The performance of commandments literally causes this very matter.

However, Torah study is superior to action, because Torah is Tiferet, which contains 613 branches—365 on the left and 248 on the right—and the commandments depend on the four-letter Name like grapes on a cluster. The same is true of the Oral Torah, which is Malkhut, wherein the 613 commandments are explained. One who engages with them day and night undoubtedly causes the

[1] This phrase uses marriage imagery to describe the unification of masculine and feminine divine aspects (Tiferet and Malkhut, or God and Shekhinah) achieved through proper religious service.
[2] This translates the kabbalistic concept of 'התעוררות למעלה' (awakening above), where human religious activities stimulate corresponding responses in the divine realms.
[3] This refers to the kabbalistic understanding of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) divided into two pairs: Yod-Heh representing the higher divine aspects (Wisdom and Understanding) and Vav-Heh representing the lower aspects (Beauty and Kingdom).

[i] The metaphor of 'bridegroom coming forth to meet the bride' describes the mystical union of masculine and feminine divine forces (Tiferet and Malkhut) that occurs through proper Torah study and prayer.
[ii] The author presents Torah as corresponding to Tiferet, with 613 branches divided into 365 negative commandments (left side, associated with restriction) and 248 positive commandments (right side, associated with expansion).

בלי ספק יחוד תורה שבכתב
115 ותורה שבעל פה והתורה מגינה
לעולם כדאמרי׳ בגמ׳ סוטה
פ״ג ועדיף דבור בפסוקי תורה
ממעשה המצות כי המקריב עולה
במעשה לא הקריב חטאת כלל
120 ואם הקריב שניהם לא מפני
זה הקריב שלמים אבל עסק
התורה כתיב בה וזאת התורה
פי׳ תורה שבכתב ושבעל פה וכן
אמרו בשבת פרק י״ח גדול ת״ת
125 יותר מהקרבת תמידין ובהיות
האדם עוסק באיזה חלק ממנה
שירצה הוא עושה שם למעלה
ומאיר בכולה וזהו זאת התורה
לעולה ולמנחה ולחטאת וגו׳.
130 וזהו דכולהו תנויי דרב יהודה
בנזיקין הוו וכולהו תנויי דההיא
צורבא מרבנן בחגיגה הוה
וכמוהם רבים. הנה כי ת״ת כנגד
כלם וכן התפלה אמרי׳ בגמ׳
135 ברכות פ״ק גדולה תפלה יותר
ממעשים טובים שהרי משה שאין
לנו גדול ממנו במעשה ולא נענה
אלא בתפלה. [i]

unification of the Written Torah and the Oral Torah, and the Torah protects the world, as they said in 115R
Tractate Sotah, chapter 3.

Speech engaged with Torah verses is superior to performing commandments, because one who offers a burnt offering in action has not offered a sin offering at all, and if one offers both, this does not 120R
mean one has offered a peace offering. But regarding Torah study it is written, "This is the Torah," meaning both the Written and Oral Torah. And they said in Tractate Shabbat, chapter 18, "Torah study is greater than offering the daily sacrifices." 125R
When a person engages with any part of it that they wish, they create a name above and illuminate the entirety. This is the meaning of "This is the Torah for the burnt offering, for the meal offering, for the sin offering, etc." This explains why all of Rav Yehu- 130R
dah's teachings were in [tractate] Nezikin, and all the teachings of that Torah scholar were in [tractate] Chagigah, and there are many like them. Thus, Torah study counterbalances them all. Similarly regarding prayer, they said in Tractate Berakhot, chap- 135R
ter 1, "Prayer is greater than good deeds, for even Moses—than whom we have none greater in deeds—was answered only through prayer."

פרק י׳ Chapter 10

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author refers to earlier chapters in this same work when mentioning 'what we wrote in previous chapters of this discourse' regarding the four types of evil inclination. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:7 — The author quotes 'Behold, the bed of Solomon, sixty mighty men surround it' from Song of Songs 3:7 and interprets it kabbalistically to explain how the Levites, who represent the side of judgment (Gevurah), served as Temple guardians at night. | Cf. Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26) — The author notes that each order of verses contains sixty, corresponding to the number of letters in the Priestly Blessing, creating a mystical correspondence between these verses and the power to 'sweeten' harsh judgments. | Cf. Proverbs 17:22 — The phrase 'a stricken spirit dries the bone' alludes to Proverbs 17:22, which the author interprets as referring to the negative spiritual forces that can affect a person. | Cf. Zohar — The text contains multiple Zoharic terms and concepts such as 'sweetening judgments,' 'sixty lashes of fire,' 'masters of wailing,' and the kabbalistic interpretation of day and night as corresponding to Chesed and Gevurah. | Cf. Tractate Sotah — The author cites Tractate Sotah to support the claim that Torah study protects the world, establishing the superior spiritual value of Torah engagement. | Cf. Tractate Shabbat — The author quotes Tractate Shabbat chapter 18 stating that 'Torah study is greater than offering the daily sacrifices' to demonstrate the superiority of Torah study over ritual actions. | Cf. Tractate Berakhot — The author cites Tractate Berakhot chapter 1 stating that 'Prayer is greater than good deeds' to establish prayer's supreme value, even above righteous actions. | Cf. Leviticus 7:37 — The phrase 'This is the Torah for the burnt offering, for the meal offering, for the sin offering, etc.' alludes to Leviticus 7:37, which the author reinterprets to mean that Torah study encompasses and substitutes for all types of offerings. | Cf. Tikunei Zohar — The reference to 'as explained in the Tikkunim' when discussing how souls clothe themselves in different spiritual realities points to teachings from Tikunei Zohar about the soul's journey after death.

הן האדם היה לנפש חיה ותרגומו
לרוח ממללא[i] על ידי נפיחת
באפיו נשמת חיים ע״כ בקולו
קול עז לעורר בכח כ״ב חפצי
יוצר בראשית ה״ה כ״ב אותיות
תורתנו הכ״ב מקורות עליונות
דאינון י״ג תקוני דיקנא דאריך
ותשעה תקוני דזעיר[ii] הנפתחים
בחכמה ובינה ודעת וענפיהם.
ואריך נכלל בז״א. נוקביה
שהוא כלל כל האצילות ע״י
פה קדוש שהוא השושבין המיחד
וממתק ומבער הקוצים מן כרם
חמד. וממתק רומחי הגבורה
על דרך שאמרו בזהר פ׳
בשלח דף קנ״א ע״ב וסיהרא
אתלבשת ברומחי גבורה בשיתין
פולסי דנורא ועשרה דילה
דנחתי מסטרא דאימא עילאה.
ובדף ס״ה אמר דשיתין אינון
דבסחריניה דשבינתא דכתיב
ששים גבורים סביב לה.[iii] ואינון
שתין אתנהירו בתריסר תחומין
וכולהו נהירין ומטרוניתא כד
אתאחדא במלכא לא אעדיאו
מסחרנותא לעלמין. נמצא
כי עיני כל למעשה התחתונים
ישברו ורב גובריהו בכח דבורם

Man became a living soul, and its translation [in Aramaic] is “a spe[1]aking spirit” through the breathing into his nostrils the breath of life. Therefore, with his voice—a powerful voice—he can awaken the twenty-two desires of the Creator of the Beginning, namely the twenty-two letters of our Torah, the twenty-two supernal sources, which are the thirteen rectifications of the beard of Arich Anpin and the nine rectifications of Zeir Anpin that open through Wisdom, Understanding, Knowledge, and their branches. And Arich is included in Zeir Anpin, and its female aspect, which encompasses all of Atzilut, through the holy mouth, which is the attendant that unifies,[2] sweetens, and removes the thorns from the desirable vineyard. And it sweetens the spears of Gevurah, as they said in the Zohar, Parashat Beshalach, page 151b: “And the moon is clothed in the spears of Gevurah, with sixty lashes of fire and ten of her own[3] that descend from the aspect of the Supernal Mother.” And on page 65, it says that “there are sixty surrounding the Shekhinah, as it is written, ‘sixty mighty ones surround her.’ And these sixty are illuminated in twelve boundaries, and they all shine, and when the Matronita unites with the King, they never depart from surrounding her.” Thus we find that the eyes of all look hopefully to the actions of those below,[4] and their great power is in the strength of their speech

[1]This reflects the Aramaic translation by Onkelos of Genesis 2:7, highlighting that the defining characteristic of humanity is the power of speech. This concept becomes central to the passage's argument about the cosmic significance of human verbal expression.

[2]The metaphor of the mouth as an ‘attendant’ (shoshvin) comes from Jewish wedding traditions, where the attendant facilitates the union between bride and groom. Here, human speech serves as the attendant that facilitates the union of divine masculine and feminine aspects.

[3]These numbers have mystical significance in Kabbalah: the sixty corresponds to the sefirah of Gevurah (Judgment) and its extensions, while the ten represents the ten sefirot emanating from the Supernal Mother (Binah).

[4]This phrase reflects the kabbalistic principle that the upper worlds depend on human actions in the lower world, inverting the more common idea that humans are dependent on divine forces above. This establishes the cosmic significance of human religious practice.

[i]This references Onkelos's Aramaic translation of Genesis 2:7, where the Hebrew ‘living soul’ (nefesh chayah) is rendered as ‘speaking spirit’ (ruach memalela), emphasizing that human speech is the defining characteristic that distinguishes humans.

[ii]This refers to the thirteen attributes of divine mercy symbolized by the ‘beard’ of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One) and nine attributes of Zeir Anpin (the Small-Faced One) in Lurianic Kabbalah. Together they form the twenty-two channels through which divine energy flows.

[iii]A quotation from Song of Songs 3:7, which in its literal context describes King Solomon's bed guarded by sixty warriors, but is interpreted kabbalistically as referring to divine protective forces surrounding the Shekhinah (Divine Presence).

להכריע השמים[i][ii] to influence the heavens.

ולזה אמרה תורה לא תסור מן הדבר אשר יגידו לך. כי ההכרעה תלויה בתחתונים שיש בידם להקל ולהחמיר לטמא ולטהר לאסור ולהתיר בכח צד הטוב והרע הנכללים מהם. ואם רוב הב״ד יטמאו ישליטו בדבר ההוא כח החצונים וטמא טמא יקרא לו בין למעלה בין למטה ואם יטהרו ישליטו בדבר ההוא מן השמים הקדושה ויהיה טהור ומושפע ממנו ואולי זה יהיה טעם מה שאמרו בגמרא דיבמות פ״ו ובמס׳ ע״ג פ״ק חכם שטמא אין חברו רשאי לטהר כשטעה בשיקול הדעת. שמיד שהחכם הראשון אסר משיקול דעתו שאין לו לדיין אלא מה שעיניו שכלו רואות בזה השליט על אותו דבר כח החצוני ואין כח בחברו להתירו כי כבר נדחה ומחוץ למחנה מושבו. ומה שאמרו בחגיגה פ״ק עשה אזנך כאפרכסת וקנה לך לב מבין לשמוע דברי האוסרים ודברי המתירים וכו׳ כי כלם נתנו מרועה אחד ופרנס אחד אמרן

Therefore, the Torah said, "Do not deviate from the word that they tell you." For the decision lies with those below, who have the power to be lenient or strict, to declare impure or pure, to forbid or permit, through the power of good and evil elements included within them. If the majority of the court declares something impure, they cause external forces to dominate in that matter, and it will be called impure both above and below.[1] And if they declare it pure, they cause holiness from heaven to dominate that matter, and it will be pure and receive divine influence.

Perhaps this explains what they said in the Talmud, Yevamot chapter 6 and in Avodah Zarah chapter 1: "If a sage declared something impure, his colleague is not permitted to declare it pure when the first sage erred in judgment." For as soon as the first sage forbade something based on his judgment—since a judge has only what his intellect perceives—he caused external forces to dominate that matter, and his colleague lacks the power to permit it, for it has already been rejected and "outside the camp is its dwelling."

Regarding what they said in Chagigah chapter 1, "Make your ear like a funnel[2] and acquire an understanding heart to hear the words of those who forbid and those who permit, etc."—for they

[1] This phrase reflects the kabbalistic principle that human decisions in the earthly court have corresponding effects in the heavenly realms.

[2] This metaphor describes the ideal approach to Torah study—being open to hearing multiple interpretations rather than closing oneself to opposing viewpoints.

[i] This expresses the fundamental kabbalistic concept that human speech has the power to influence higher celestial realms, establishing a reciprocal relationship between human ritual actions and cosmic processes.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 2:7 — The passage begins with a reference to Genesis 2:7, where God breathes life into Adam's nostrils, making him a living soul. The author reinterprets this act through a kabbalistic lens, suggesting that this divine breath enables humans to activate cosmic forces through speech. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Beshalach — The author directly quotes the Zohar to establish how human speech activates celestial forces, particularly how the 'spears of Gevurah' (forces of judgment) can be sweetened or mitigated through proper speech. The reference to 'sixty mighty ones' alludes to Song of Songs 3:7-8, which the Zohar interprets as cosmic forces of protection. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:7-8 — The Zohar passage cited by the author reinterprets the sixty mighty men surrounding Solomon's bed as mystical forces surrounding the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). This establishes the cosmic significance of proper speech and intention, suggesting that human words below can activate protective divine forces above. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) — The passage references the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet as 'desires of the Creator,' echoing the teaching from Sefer Yetzirah that the letters were the divine instruments of creation. This establishes why human speech using these same letters has cosmic creative power.

מפי אדון כל המעשים ברוך הוא.
עיין דרוש זה בסוף מעירי שחר
שלנו דבד פליגי תרי אמוראי
אליבא דנפשייהו למה אמרי׳
בהו אלו ואלו דברי אלהים חיים
וזה מתבאר בגמ׳ דתענית פ״ב
ובסוטה פ״ג. ולהיות כח זה
בתחתונים להקל ולהחמיר בזה
נבין כוונת ר׳ יהושע באומרו נגד
הבת קול לא בשמים היא ואין אנו
משגיחין בבת קול ופי׳ נצחוני
בני נצחוני בב״מ פ״ד שודאי
כן הוא שהקב״ה רצון יראיו
יעשה וצדיק מושל יראת אלהים
ונוטה אל הבחינה שהצדיקים
מטין אותו כי אפי׳ ירצה לישב
על כסא דין ויהיו רוב הדברים
נוטין לטומאה או לחיוב הצדיק
מקימו מכסא דין ויושב על
כסא רחמים וכיוצא והכל טהור
וזכאי. ובדאמרי׳ בזהר פ׳
ויחי כי יצתה בת קול ואמרה
בורסייא דמריה אחידא בגדפוהי
דר״ש וכו׳. וראיה לזה ג״כ מה
שאמרו בחגיגה פ׳ אין דורשין
דשיליה רבה בר רב שילא
לאליהו מאי קעביד קוב״ה א״ל
קאמר הלכה משמא דכלהו רבנן
ומפומיה דר״מ לא קאמר א״ל
אמאי א״ל מפני שלמד מאלישע
א״ל ר״מ רימון מצא וגו׳ אמר
ליה השתא מאי קאמר וגו׳. הנה
כי דינו של אלישע היה תלוי
ועומד עד כי תצא ההכרעה מפי
התחתונים והסכימו להכרעת
רבה כי ר״מ היה חבוש ולא היה
יכול להתיר עצמו בטענתו עד
כי יהפך בזכותו אחד מחבריו
או מתלמידיו וכן דייק רש״י
שאמר עכשיו שמע לקולך שאומר
שמועה מפיו. ותוס׳ העמיקו
יותר באומרם כי בתחלה היה

all were given by one Shepherd,[1] and one Provider spoke them from the mouth of the Master of all deeds, blessed is He. See our discussion of this at the end of Me'irei Shachar, regarding why, when two Amoraim disagree according to their own reasoning, we say about them, "These and these are the words of the Living God." This is explained in the Talmud, Ta'anit chapter 2 and Sotah chapter 3. 60R

Since this power resides with those below to be lenient or strict, we can understand Rabbi Joshua's intention when he said against the Heavenly Voice, "It is not in heaven," and "We pay no attention to a Heavenly Voice." And the explanation of "My children have defeated Me" in Bava Metzia chapter 4 is that indeed, the Holy One, blessed be He, fulfills the desire of those who fear Him, and "the righteous rule through the fear of God."[2] He inclines toward the perspective that the righteous direct Him to, for even if He wishes to sit on the throne of judgment, and most matters tend toward impurity or guilt, the righteous lift Him from the throne of judgment and seat Him on the throne of mercy, and similarly, everything becomes pure and innocent. 65R 70R 75R

As they said in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi, that a Heavenly Voice went forth and said, "The throne of his Master is held in the wings of Rabbi Shimon, etc." And proof of this is also what they said in Chagigah, in the chapter "Ein Dorshin," that Rabbah bar Rav Shila asked Elijah, "What is the Holy One, blessed be He, doing?" He replied, "He is stating legal rulings in the name of all the sages, but from the mouth of Rabbi Meir, He does not state them." Rabbah asked, "Why?" He answered, "Because he learned from Elisha." Rabbah said, "Rabbi Meir found a pomegranate, etc."[3] Elijah then said to him, "Now what is He saying, etc." 80R 85R 90R

Behold, Elisha's judgment was pending until a decision came from those below, and they agreed with Rabbah's decision. For Rabbi Meir was imprisoned and could not free himself with his own argument until one of his colleagues or disciples championed his cause. And Rashi was precise when he said, 95R

[1] A reference to God as the ultimate source of Torah, despite apparent contradictions in rabbinic interpretations.

[2] This is a reference to 2 Samuel 23:3, which is being interpreted here to suggest that righteous scholars have authority to influence even divine judgment.

[3] This references the Talmudic metaphor comparing Rabbi Meir to someone who finds a pomegranate—he ate the fruit (took the valuable teachings) and discarded the peel (rejected the problematic aspects of his teacher).

המקום בכעס על ר״מ ואח״כ
נתפיים בזכות שלמד רבה עליו
הנה שהברעות התורה וגם הרבה
מדיני הנשמות תלוי בתחתונים
וע״כ גזרו קדמונים מלהוציא
שם רע על המתים פן ח״ו יגבירו
בקטרוגם עליו הדינים. וזהו
גדול כחן של צדיקים שמהפכין
מדת הדין לרחמים ועל דרך זה
יהיה החטייה העליונה תלויה
למטה [i]

"Now He listens to your voice when you state a teaching in his name." And Tosafot delved deeper, saying that at first, God was angry with Rabbi Meir, but afterward was appeased through Rabbah's defense of him. 100R

Thus, the decisions of Torah and many of the laws concerning souls depend on those below. Therefore, the ancients decreed against speaking ill of the dead,[1] lest, God forbid, they strengthen the forces of judgment against him through their accusations. This illustrates the great power of the righteous, who transform the attribute of judgment into mercy, and in this way, the heavenly inclination depends on what happens below. 105R 110R

כי התורה אגודת עליונים עם
התחתונים.[ii] ובהיות נבואה
בישראל ע״י השתלשלות הדבור
שהיה בנביא. נמצא שכמעט כל
ישראל היו נביאים. ומה יעשה
התורה בכללה שכלה שמותיו
של הקב״ה[iii] כי לנו יש לדעת
שנבואת הנביאים היה פעמים
באותיות גדולות או בקטנות
ובאותיות לפופות[iv] ופעמים
כתיב ולא קרי קרי ולא
כתיב[v] וח״ו לא אירע זה מחמת

For the Torah is a bond between the celestial and terrestrial beings. And when prophecy existed in Israel through the emanation of speech that was in the prophet, it was as if almost all of Israel were prophets.[2] And what does the Torah as a whole accomplish, which is entirely composed of the names of the Holy One, blessed be He? For we must know that the prophecy of the prophets sometimes appeared in large letters, sometimes in small ones, sometimes in wrapped letters, sometimes written but not read, or read but not written. Heaven forbid that this occurred due to confusion or difficulty, as some have 115R 120R

[1] The text connects this prohibition to the kabbalistic belief that negative speech about the deceased can strengthen negative spiritual forces against them in the afterlife.

[2] The author is making a bold claim here about the democratization of prophecy through the Torah. This reflects the kabbalistic view that Torah study can produce experiences similar to prophecy, elevating ordinary Jews to near-prophetic status.

[i] Cf. Talmud Bava Metzia 59b — The passage references the famous Talmudic story of the 'oven of Akhnai' where Rabbi Joshua declared 'It is not in heaven,' rejecting divine intervention in halakhic decision-making and establishing human authority in legal interpretation. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The text cites this Zoharic passage to demonstrate how exceptional righteous individuals can influence divine judgment, with Rabbi Shimon being so spiritually elevated that God's throne is metaphorically held in his 'wings' or spiritual domain. | Cf. Talmud Chagigah 15b — The passage uses this Talmudic story to illustrate that even divine judgment awaits and responds to human interpretations and decisions, specifically how Rabbah bar Rav Shila's defense of Rabbi Meir influenced the heavenly treatment of his teachings.

[ii] This is a foundational kabbalistic concept that the Torah serves as a cosmic bond connecting the upper and lower worlds, functioning as a metaphysical bridge between heaven and earth.

[iii] This refers to the kabbalistic teaching that the entire Torah is composed of divine names, not just narratives and laws. This concept appears in the Zohar and was particularly emphasized by Rabbi Moses Cordovero and other Safed kabbalists.

[iv] The author refers to various scribal features of the Torah text, including oversized letters, miniature letters, and curved or wrapped letters, all of which are traditionally understood to contain mystical significance.

[v] These are technical terms in Masoretic textual tradition referring to words that are written in the Torah scroll but not read aloud, or words that are read aloud but not written in the scroll.

בלבול או טרחה כאשר כתבו
קצת. כי תורת ה׳ תמימה מכל
צדדיה. ולא לחנם נדו גדולי
האחרונים והורידו מהתיבה
אותו שלא רצה לקרות הקרי
כתיב כפי המסורת כאשר
הביא מהרר״י קאר״ו[i] בסוף
סי׳ קמ״א שכתב שכל תיבה
שהיא קרי כתיב הלכה למשה
מסיני[ii] שתהא נכתבת כמו שהיא
בתורה ונקרא בענין אחר. הנה
כי הכל היה מלמעלה שהיה
הדבור בפי הנביא מתהוה
בשכלו ובפיו ומתחוקק כאלו
רואה וצופה הדברים המתהוים
ומצטיירים כדכתיב וכל העם
רואים את הקולות ופי׳ רואים
את הנשמע. דוגמא זו כתב בעל
יפה מראה[iii] על מעשה דשמעון
הצדיק[iv] דאמרו בגמרין ובירו׳
אמר להון מן אמר לי דהוה בר
נש אני אומר הקב״ה הוה. וכתב
י״ל שאור השכינה הנראה לעין
על דרך ומראה כבוד ה׳ הוא
שנגלה לפניו כזקן ועד״ז בר׳
ישמעאל כ״ג[v] שמראה כבוד ה׳
הנראה נתגלה לפניו יושב על
כסא רם ונשא. והנביא בנבואתו
היה שומע הקול ונכתב לפניו
בטעמו ונקודותיו ואותיותיו
מנוקדות למעלה ובטעמיהן או
פעמים אותיות לפופות מזויינות
בתגיהן וכיוצא וגם בעת שהנביא

written. For the Torah of the Lord is perfect in all its aspects. And it was not for nothing that later authorities excommunicated and removed from the pulpit one who refused to read the keri-ketiv according to tradition,[1] as Rabbi Joseph Karo brought at the end of section 141, where he wrote that every word that is keri-ketiv is a law given to Moses at Sinai, that it should be written as it is in the Torah but read differently. Indeed, everything came from above, as the speech in the prophet's mouth formed in his mind and on his lips, and was engraved as if he were seeing and observing things as they formed and took shape, as it is written, "And all the people saw the sounds," interpreted as "they saw what is heard."[2] A similar example was written by the author of Yefeh Mareh regarding the incident with Simeon the Righteous, as they said in our Talmud, and in the Jerusalem Talmud he said to them, "Who told me it was a man? I say it was the Holy One, blessed be He." And he wrote that one might say that the light of the Divine Presence visible to the eye, in the manner of "and the appearance of the glory of the Lord," is what appeared before him as an elder. And similarly with Rabbi Ishmael the High Priest, as the appearance of the glory of the Lord appeared before him seated on a high and exalted throne. And the prophet in his prophecy would hear the voice and it would be written before him with its cantillation and its vowel points, and its letters punctuated above with their cantillation marks, or sometimes wrapped letters adorned with their crowns and so forth. And also when the prophet would speak the prophecy to Israel, the prophecy would emerge from his mouth to

[1] This refers to words in the Hebrew Bible that are written one way (ketiv) but read aloud differently (keri). The author views these not as textual errors but as divinely ordained features containing mystical significance.

[2] This synesthetic interpretation of Exodus 20:15 is common in Jewish mystical texts and describes the transcendent sensory experience at Sinai, where normal sensory boundaries dissolved.

[i] This refers to Rabbi Joseph Karo (1488-1575), author of the Shulchan Aruch, the most widely accepted code of Jewish law.

[ii] This phrase indicates a law considered to have been transmitted directly to Moses at Sinai, giving it the highest level of authority in Jewish tradition.

[iii] This refers to Rabbi Samuel Jaffe Ashkenazi (1525-1595), author of Yefeh Mareh, a commentary on the Jerusalem Talmud.

[iv] Simeon the Righteous was a High Priest during the Second Temple period, mentioned in Pirkei Avot as one of the last members of the Great Assembly.

[v] Rabbi Ishmael the High Priest, whose mystical vision of God enthroned is recorded in the Talmud and became a central text in early Jewish mysticism.

אומר הנבואה לישראל היתה הנבואה יוצאת מפיו להם באימה וביראה כאלו היתה השבינה עמו ממש. והיינו ונתתי דברי בפיו ודבר אליהם את כל אשר אצונו וזה צורך גבוה וצורך ישראל כדי שיהיה מצוי הקשר בין ישראל לאביהם שבשמים על ידי הנביא כאלו היו כלם נביאים. אמת מה נהדר כח הדבור הקדוש באדם: [i]

them with awe and fear,[1] as if the Divine Presence were literally with him. And this is the meaning of "And I will put My words in his mouth, and he shall speak to them all that I command him." And this serves both a higher purpose and Israel's need, so that the connection between Israel and their Father in heaven would be present through the prophet, as if they were all prophets. Truly, how majestic is the power of holy speech in man![2]

פרק י״א

Chapter 11

עוד יבין וידע האדם כי יש עתות ראוים לתורה ולתפלה ולייחודים ולמעשים טובים יותר מובנים מעת אחר. ולכן אל יתרשל אדם עצמו בבא מצוה לידו ויהיה רץ כצבי לעשות רצון קונו כי פעמים יפגע אדם בעניינים רוחניים מחמת מצוה שעשה או לסבה אחרת או להיות אז עת רצון יתגלה לפני מקור נשמתו למעלה וכמו כן יופיע למטה לפניו עת וזמן הראוי לאיזה יחוד עליון ויבא פעם אחת בידו אם יעשהו אז מוטב ואם לא ברוח יברח ממנו ולא ישוב אליו עד כמה דורות ולזה הבדיל משה שלש ערים ורמזו לזה באמרם עשה עד שאתה מוצא

A person should further understand and recognize that there are times more conducive to Torah study, prayer, unifications, and good deeds than other times. Therefore, one should not be lazy when the opportunity to perform a mitzvah presents itself, but rather run like a gazelle[3] to fulfill the will of his Creator. For sometimes a person may encounter spiritual matters due to a mitzvah he performed, or for another reason, or because it is then a time of divine favor when the source of his soul is revealed above, and similarly, a time and season suitable for some higher unification will appear before him below. If he seizes this opportunity when it comes to him, good; but if not, it will flee from him with the wind and not return until after many generations. This is why Moses set apart three cities[4] [of refuge], and the Sages alluded to this when they said, "Act while you find the opportunity and it is available to

[1] The Hebrew terms 'eimah' and 'yirah' have specific theological connotations, indicating not just psychological states but proper spiritual responses to divine manifestation.

[2] This concluding statement reflects the kabbalistic emphasis on the power of human speech as a creative force, mirroring divine creative speech. This concept underlies many Jewish mystical practices involving the recitation of divine names and sacred texts.

[3] This is an allusion to Pirkei Avot 5:20, which instructs one to 'be bold as a leopard, light as an eagle, swift as a deer, and strong as a lion to do the will of your Father in Heaven.'

[4] Refers to the cities of refuge that Moses established (Deuteronomy 4:41-43). The author interprets this action mystically as relating to seizing spiritual opportunities.

[i] Cf. Exodus 19:6 — The author draws on the idea that all Israelites had a direct connection to God, interpreting the priestly status mentioned in Exodus as a form of prophetic status. | Cf. Exodus 20:15 (20:18 in Christian Bibles) — The author uses this verse to illustrate that prophecy involved a sensory experience that transcended normal perception, where visual and auditory senses merged. | Cf. Yoma 39a-b — The author uses this story to support the idea that prophetic experiences involved actual visual manifestations of divine entities. | Cf. Berakhot 7a — This reference provides another example of direct divine visual experience, supporting the author's claims about the nature of prophecy. | Cf. Jeremiah 1:9 — The author cites this to demonstrate that prophetic speech is directly from God, not the prophet's own creation.

ומצוי בידך וזה סוד כי יקרא קן
צפור לפניך[i] וגו׳ וזה כלל גדול
והודעה רבה להיות כעבד ישאף
צל וכשכיר יקוה פעולת המצות
והיחודים ויהיה רץ למצוה קלה
כבחמורה ויפיק רצון מה׳. עיני
האדם לנוכח יביטו ועפעפיו
יישירו נגדו ומפחד החצוני יעשה
לו כנפים כנשרים וממנו ברוח
יברח וזהו גדר הירא חטא וידע
ויבין כי כפי המדרגה שהאדם
רוצה להתקדש עצמו בה ודרך
ההוא ח״ו שטן יעמוד על שמאלו
שכל דבר מתגבר נגד הפכו כמו
שראינו בחדה״ר[ii] ובנח וישראל
אחר שקבלו התורה שפסקה
מהם זוהמא וכן כשהיו מוכנים
ליכנס לארץ לשבור הקליפה
כאשר דרשנו למעלה כי ס״מ זה
דרכו בסל לו להשים כחותיו
נגד כחות הקדושה גם את זה
לעומת זה. וזהו שכל הגדול
מחבירו יצרו גדול הימנו. ואמרו
בר״מ בפ׳ נשא דף קנ״ד בזמנא
דאית לב״נ נשמה שפירא וכל
עובדין טבין יצר הרע אית ליה
קנאה ולזמנין שליט עלה בחובין
ומסאב לה ואתקריאת נבלה.
שכפי שהוא נכנס אל הקדושה
כן הנגדי עומד על שמאלו לנכח
הימין על כן אמרו בגמרין
שלשה צריכין חזוק. תורה.
ומעשים טובים. ודרך ארץ.
ואם יזכה להתחזק יטול חלקו

you." This is the secret of "If a bird's nest happens
to be before you" (Deuteronomy 22:6), and this is a
great principle and significant instruction to be like
a servant who longs for shade and like a laborer who
hopes for the reward of mitzvot and unifications,
running toward a minor commandment as toward a
major one, and obtaining favor from God.

A person's eyes should look straight ahead and
his eyelids be directed before him, and out of fear of
the external forces, he should make wings for himself
like eagles[A] and flee. This is the definition of one
who fears sin. He should know and understand that
according to the level at which a person seeks to sanc-
tify himself, Satan—Heaven forbid—will stand at his
left, for everything strengthens against its opposit[1]e.
We have seen this with Adam, with Noah, with Israel
after they received the Torah when impurity ceased
from them,[2] and similarly when they were prepared
to enter the land to break the shell [of evil], as we
explained above. For Samael's foolish way is to po-
sition his forces against the forces of holiness, "this
opposite that." This is why one who is greater than
his fellow has a greater evil inclination.

And they said in Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat
Naso, page 154: "When a person has a beautiful
soul and all good deeds, the evil inclination becomes
jealous, and sometimes it prevails over it through
sins and defiles it, and it is called 'carcass.'" For
just as one enters into holiness, so does the opposing
force stand at his left opposite his right. Therefore,
they said in the Talmud that three things require
strengthening: Torah, good deeds, and proper
conduct. If one merits to strengthen himself, he
will take his portion and his fellow's portion in the

[A] Or: "and out of fear of negative spiritual forces, he should soar swiftly like eagles" — This alternative translation captures the metaphorical meaning more directly, emphasizing the rapid spiritual ascent rather than the literal 'making of wings.' It might be preferable in contexts where the practical spiritual instruction is emphasized over the literal imagery.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic principle that cosmic forces strengthen in opposition to each other, creating a spiritual battlefield where holiness and impurity contend in direct proportion.

[2] This refers to the Talmudic teaching (Shabbat 146a) that when Israel stood at Mount Sinai, their spiritual impurity (zohama) ceased, though it returned after the sin of the golden calf.

[i] This verse (Deuteronomy 22:6) about a bird's nest is interpreted mystically as a metaphor for spiritual opportunities that present themselves unexpectedly. The author uses this biblical commandment, which speaks of finding a bird's nest by chance, to illustrate the concept of seizing spiritual moments.

[ii] This is an abbreviation for חייו דאדם הראשון (Chayei d'Adam HaRishon), referring to Adam, the first human.

וחלק חברו שבגן עדן כדאמרי׳
בחגיגה פרק ב׳ וכן הכתוב
55 אומר לכן בארצם משנה יירשו
וברשעים הנענים ליצרם כתיב
בהם ומשנה שברון שברם וכמה
פעמים זחלתי ואירא לנפשי פן
יסית אותי לבקש מצדקי למפטר
60 נפשי מההרגל יחודי פסוקים
אלו להיותם ממתקים הדינים
ומנגדים לכוונתו החפץ תמיד
להגדיל המדורה ואש וגפרית
מנת כוסו. ע״כ בכל דבר קדושה
65 יאחז צדיק דרכו ובצדקתו
יחזיק ולא ירפה והכוונה בכלל
תהיה בהם להמשיך השפע מבעל
הרצון המעולה על כל ברכה
ותהלה ויכוין כי בתקון מספר
70 ס׳ שהזכרנו בפ״ט עצמו עם
שרשי נשמות ישראל העולם
ממספר פרטי למספר גדול עד
ס׳ רבוא וכל ישראל חברים הם
במחצב נשמותיהם[i] כדכתיב כל
75 הנשמה תהלל יה. לשון יחיד. על
כן הם ערבים זה לזה. ובודאי
כי בהשתתף עצמו עם תקון
כלליותיהם של עם ישראל בזה
יגרום שפע והרוחה לישראל.
80 ויכוין עוד להפוך כל הכ״ח
עתים י״ד לרחמים וי״ד לדין
לרחמים כי אפי׳ בשעת כעסו
של הקב״ה זוכר את הרחמים
כדאמרי׳ בברכות ובפסחים
85 פ׳ כיצד צולין ולפחות מס׳ אי
אפשר שכן אמרו בתרומה עין
רעה אחד מששים ובפאה אין
פותחין מששים וגם אנחנו שתין
רהיטי נרהיט ממטה למעלה
90 להרים תקון כולל ופרטי
למיישרי דרכם. ובראש ששים
אלו באו שמנה פסוקי תורה נגד
תורה שבכתב ושבעל פה. דאינון

Garden of Eden, as we say in Hagigah, chapter 2. And so the verse states, "Therefore in their land they shall possess double" (Isaiah 61:7), while 55R
regarding the wicked who yield to their inclination, it is written, "And with double destruction, destroy them" (Jeremiah 17:18).

How many times I have trembled and feared for myself lest it entice me to seek excuses to exempt my- 60R
self from the practice of unifying these verses, which sweeten the judgments[1] and oppose its intention, which always desires to increase the bonfire with fire and brimstone as its portion. Therefore, in every matter of holiness, the righteous person should hold 65R
firmly to his way, strengthen his righteousness, and not let go. The general intention in these [verses] should be to draw down divine flow from the Master of supreme Will, who is beyond all blessing and praise. One should intend that through the cor- 70R
rection of the number sixty that we mentioned in chapter 9, along with the root souls of Israel, the world ascends from individual numbers to the great number of 600,000. All Israel are connected in the quarry of their souls, as it is written, "Let every soul 75R
(in singular) praise the Lord" (Psalms 150:6)—in the singular. Therefore, they are guarantors for one another. And certainly, by associating oneself with the general restoration of the people of Israel, one causes abundance and relief for Israel. 80R

One should further intend to transform all twenty-eight times—fourteen to mercy and fourteen to judgment—into mercy, for even in the moment of the Holy One's anger, He remembers mercy, as we say in Berakhot and in Pesachim, chapter "How 85R
do we roast." And less than sixty is impossible, for they said regarding terumah that a stingy eye [gives] one-sixtieth, and regarding peah [the corner of the field left for the poor], one doesn't begin with less than one-sixtieth. And we too shall run sixty courses 90R
from below to above to raise a comprehensive and specific restoration to straighten their paths.

At the beginning of these sixty [verses] come eight

[1] Hamtakat ha-dinim (sweetening the judgments) is a key kabbalistic concept referring to the transformation of divine severity into mercy through proper spiritual practice.

[i] The phrase 'quarry of their souls' refers to the kabbalistic concept that all Jewish souls originate from a unified spiritual source, explaining their metaphysical interconnection and mutual responsibility.

אותיות הוי״ה ואדנו״ת[i] כי ה׳
95 בהיכל קדשו ויחדו הם תמים ולא
יתפרדו כנדרש לעיל בשם ספר
הזהר וכבר אמרנו שכל תורה
ותפלה ועבודה תהיה מגמת פניו
ליחד קול ודבור דאינון קב״ה
100 ושכינתיה והמחשבה בקריאה
להמשיך השפע מחכמה והתורה
נגד ת״ת זעיר. ואח״כ ימשיך
לזרועות זעיר שמתפשטות
בעולם הבריאה והם ג״כ שמנה
105 פסוקים לרמוז תמורת שמות אלו
הנזכרים. אח״כ ימשיך מתורה
לנביאים שהם נגד התפשטות
נצחים של זעיר בעולם היצירה
עולם דמטטרו״ן ומספרם ל״ג
110 ליחוד שלש שמות הוי״ה אהי״ה
אדנו״ת כי במילואם הם ל״ב
אותיות ועם הכולל הם ל״ג.
אח״כ ימשיך מתלים לשאר
כתובים שהם רמז למלכות
115 זעיר. המתפשטות בעולם העשיה
רוחנית וגשמית ומספרם אחד
עשר לסכור פי דוברי עתק. ה״ה
עשתי עשרה יריעות שנהבים
תוכיים וקופיים[ii] ומתנגדים לכל
120 שואל לעכב תפלתו ובקשתו
ח״ו. ובזה מלאך רע יענה אמן
בע״כ:[iii]

verses from the Torah, corresponding to the Written and Oral Torah, which are the letters of the di- 95R
vine names YHVH and ADNY, for "the Lord is in His holy temple" (Psalms 11:4), and together they are perfect and will not be separated, as explained above in the name of the Zohar. And we have already said that all Torah, prayer, and divine ser- 100R
vice should aim to unify voice and speech, which are the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence, and through reading with proper intention to draw divine flow from Wisdom, with the Torah corresponding to Tiferet of Zeir Anpin. Afterward, 105R
one extends to the arms of Zeir Anpin that spread into the World of Beriah, and these are also eight verses alluding to the substitution of these aforementioned names. Then one extends from Torah to Prophets, which correspond to the extension of the 110R
Netzach [attributes] of Zeir Anpin in the World of Yetzirah, the world of Metatron, and they number thirty-three for the unification of the three names YHVH, EHYEH, ADNY, for in their full spelling they contain thirty-two letters, and with the inclu- 115R
sive number they are thirty-three. Then one extends from Psalms to the other Writings, which allude to the Malkhut of Zeir Anpin that extends into the World of Asiyah, both spiritual and physical, and they number eleven, to seal the mouths of those who 120R
speak arrogantly. These are the eleven curtains of ivory, peacocks, and monkeys,[A] which oppose every

[A] Or: "These are the eleven veils representing superficial luxuries and distractions" — This

[i] These are two primary divine names in Kabbalah: the Tetragrammaton (יהוה) representing God's transcendent aspect and Adonai (אדני) representing God's immanent aspect. Their unification is considered a primary spiritual goal in kabbalistic practice.

[ii] This is an allusion to 1 Kings 10:22, which mentions exotic items brought to King Solomon: ivory, peacocks, and monkeys. Here these terms are used metaphorically to represent external forces that oppose spiritual elevation.

[iii] Cf. Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Naso — The author cites this section of the Zohar to demonstrate how the evil inclination becomes jealous of those with beautiful souls and good deeds, supporting his argument about the spiritual opposition that arises as one reaches higher levels of holiness. | Cf. If a bird's nest happens to be before you — The author uses this verse as a mystical allusion to spiritual opportunities that appear unexpectedly before a person, which should be seized immediately since they may not return. | Cf. Therefore in their land they shall possess double — Used to show the spiritual reward for those who strengthen themselves against their evil inclination—they receive both their own portion and that of the wicked in the Garden of Eden. | Cf. And with double destruction, destroy them — Contrasted with the Isaiah verse to show the dual punishment awaiting those who yield to their evil inclination, creating a symmetrical concept of double reward versus double punishment. | Cf. Let every soul praise the Lord — The author notes that 'soul' appears in the singular form in this verse despite referring to all Israel, using this to demonstrate the mystical unity of all Jewish souls, which makes them spiritually responsible for one another. | Cf. the Lord is in His holy temple — Used to illustrate the unification of divine names (YHVH and ADNY), showing how they exist in perfect harmony and cannot be separated in proper kabbalistic understanding.

petitioner to delay his prayer and request, Heaven forbid. And through this, even the evil angel answers "Amen" against its will.[1] 125R

פרק י״ב

Chapter 12

זאת ועוד הנה שכרו אתו ופעלתו לפניו בזה כי נמצא חורז פעמים בכל יום מתורה לנביאים ומנביאים לכתובים וכו׳ והדברים שמחים בחמש גבורות שבבינה[i] מתמתקים על הדרך שמקבלים מיתוק מחמש ענויים של יוה״כ[ii] באופן שהחמשה ספירות שבמקומם הם מתלהטין ופועלים דין עתה בזה מתבסמין ומתהפכין לרחמים וחמשה מיני דמים שבאשה נדה[iii] ספו תמו ונשקעים בנוקבא דתהומא רבא[iv] ומשם יורדים במצולות ים. ואפי׳ מי שלא ידע לכוין לזה וביוצא בזה בהרגילו

Furthermore, behold his reward is with him and his recompense before him, for by doing this he weaves together each day passages from Torah to Prophets and from Prophets to Writings,[2] etc. The verses rejoice in the five powers of Binah[A] and are sweetened 5R
in the manner that they receive sweetening from the five afflictions of Yom Kippur.[3] In this way, the five sefirot that in their place would burn fiercely and effect judgment are now sweetened and transformed into mercy, and the five types of blood of the menstruating woman are eliminated and sink into the opening of the great abyss,[B4] 10R
from where they descend into the depths of the sea. Even one who does not know how to direct his intention to this or similar matters, by habitually reciting these verses, will 15R
be diligent and rewarded, for he will merit study-

alternative interpretation focuses on the metaphorical meaning of these exotic items (from 1 Kings 10:22) as representing worldly distractions rather than directly translating the Hebrew terms. It might be preferable in contexts where the symbolic meaning needs to be immediately clear to readers unfamiliar with these biblical references.

[A] Or: "five aspects of judgment rooted in Binah" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the connection to divine judgment (gevurot) while maintaining the reference to the sefirah of Binah.

[B] Or: "feminine aspect of the great deep" — This more literal translation preserves the gender aspect of the original term 'nukva' (feminine), which has kabbalistic significance in the cosmic balance between masculine and feminine forces.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that properly performed spiritual practices compel even opposing spiritual forces to acknowledge their efficacy and contribute to the cosmic harmony.

[2] The author uses the metaphor of 'weaving' (חורז) to describe the practice of moving through different sections of Scripture in a systematic way, suggesting this creates a spiritually beneficial pattern or fabric.

[3] The concept of 'sweetening' (מתמתקים) is central to Lurianic Kabbalah, referring to the transformation of divine judgment into mercy through proper spiritual practice.

[4] This vivid metaphor describes how negative forces are neutralized through proper spiritual practice, being removed from the cosmic system where they could cause harm.

[i] This refers to the five aspects of divine judgment rooted in the sefirah of Binah (Understanding), a kabbalistic concept where severity is ultimately rooted in a higher divine attribute associated with mercy.

[ii] The five 'afflictions' prohibited on Yom Kippur: eating/drinking, washing, anointing, wearing leather shoes, and marital relations. The author creates a mystical parallel between these ritual prohibitions and the sweetening of divine judgments.

[iii] The five types of menstrual blood categorized in rabbinic literature. In this kabbalistic context, they symbolize aspects of judgment or impurity that can be transformed through proper spiritual practice.

[iv] Literally 'the female/opening of the great deep.' In Kabbalah, this refers to a cosmic location where negative forces and judgments are contained and neutralized.

בהם יהיה זריז ונשכר כי יזכה
לשנות בכל יום תורה נביאים
וכתובים. וזמר בכל יום זמר
בכל יום. ופרש״י בפ׳ חלק
שר״ע היה אומר שזמרת האדם
בלימוד בעה״ז יגרום לו שיהיה
לעה״ב בשמחה ובשירים ואמרו
שם כל הקורא פסוק בזמנו מביא
טובה לעולם. ומי שאינו קובע
עתים לתורה בכל יום תמיד
ויוצא לפעלו ולעבודתו עדי
ערב. נא בלשון בקשה יהיו
אזניו קשובות לתחנתי ולבקשתי
אליו כעבד השואל מטו מאדוניו
יגמול נא חסד של אמת זו עם
נפשו כי ודאי גמולו ישולם לו
ולא ימושו מפיהו ומפי בניו
הסדרים אלו בכל יום וחשיך
תקון נפשך בהון וקדים תקון
נפשך ורהוטו צדיקי למעבד
רעותא דמרייכו. ואם להקל
מעליו יראה לאומרם בפעם אחת
או בהרבה פעמים בין ביום בין
בלילה כל עידנא זמנייהו ונפשו
בטוב תלין עם כחות הקדושה
וזרעו יירש ארץ כי יקיים מצות
והגית בו יומם ולילה ולא ימוש
ספר התורה מפיו ואז יצליח
את דרכיו ויהיה ח״ו מוטלת על
הבריות ואמרו בגמ׳ סנהדרין
פ״ט כל אדם שיש עליו חן
בידוע שהוא ירא שמים שנאמר
וחסד ה׳ מעולם ועד עולם על
יראיו. ובראש כלם יעשה נחת
רוח ליוצרו ויקרא וה׳ יענהו.
ודבר זה מצוה לאומרו בפני
עם הארץ כדאמר רבא במס׳
מנחות פרק י״א[i] על קריאת
שמע ערבית ושחרית דפליג על
ר״י שאמר משום רשב״י בהפך.
ובכל מקום שמצאתי און לי
להשלים כוונתי בלי שנות סדר

ing Torah, Prophets, and Writings every day. And
song every day, song every day. Rashi explained in
chapter Chelek that Rabbi Akiva would say that a
person's song in study in this world will cause him to 20R
be in joy and songs in the World to Come. And they
said there that whoever recites a verse at its proper
time brings good to the world. And as for one who
does not set fixed times for Torah study every day
and goes forth to his work and labor until evening, 25R
please—this is a language of request—let his ears
be attentive to my supplication and my request to
him, like a servant who asks a favor from his master.
Let him bestow this true kindness upon his soul, for
certainly his reward will be paid to him, and these 30R
arrangements will not depart from his mouth or from
the mouth of his children every day. Seek your soul's
rectification through them[1] and prioritize your soul's
rectification, and let the righteous run to do the will
of their Master. And if to make it easier for him- 35R
self, he should see fit to recite them once or multiple
times, whether by day or by night, whenever is their
time, his soul will abide in goodness with the forces
of holiness, and his seed shall inherit the land, for he
will fulfill the commandment "you shall meditate on 40R
it day and night" and "this book of the Torah shall
not depart from your mouth." Then he will make his
ways successful and will not be, God forbid, a burden
upon others. They said in the Gemara Sanhedrin,
chapter 9, "Any person who has grace upon him, it 45R
is known that he fears Heaven, as it is said: 'And the
kindness of the Lord is from everlasting to everlasting
upon those who fear Him.'" And above all, he will
bring satisfaction to his Creator, and he will call and
the Lord will answer him. And it is a commandment 50R
to say this before the unlearned, as Rava said in Trac-
tate Menachot, chapter 11, regarding the recitation
of the Shema in the evening and morning, where he
disagrees with Rabbi Yehuda, who said in the name
of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai the opposite. And in 55R
every place where I found strength to fulfill my inten-
tion without changing the order of verses from the
way they are written in the Torah, Prophets, and

[1] The Aramaic phrase 'חשיך תקון נפשך בהון' conveys urgency, literally 'hasten the rectification of your soul through them,' emphasizing the importance of these practices for spiritual development.

[i] The author references a Talmudic dispute in Menachot 99b regarding minimum Torah study requirements, using this as support for his approach of making Scripture recitation accessible even to those who cannot study all day.

הפסוקים מהאופן הכתובים
בתורה נביאים וכתובים הנחתי
אותם על סדרם הנכון הערוך
וסדור בנבואה ורוח הקדש כי
בזה יפה כחם להפיק רצון כל
שואל כי בעת שבעמדם יעמודו
גם בהנשאם מעל הארץ ינשאו
האופנים לעומתם והבלא דפומא
מפיק הבלא עילאה ועל זה אמר
ר׳ זירא בשבת פ״ב אלמלא לא
אתינא אלא למשמע דא דיי. וכל
קול וקול יש לו שביל בפ״ע
כדאמרי׳ בבתרא פ״ק. ורוח
החיות עליון באופנים הכתובים
איש על מקומו בשלום ובזה יזכה
בכל יום לשפוך שיחו במספר
מפקד ק״כ פסוקים ששים בבקר
וששים לעתותי ערב למיתוק ק״כ
צירופי אלהים[i] ויכוין להבדיל
השלש אלהים קדושים שהם
בבינה וגבורה ומלכות מאלהים
אחרים ח״ו וזה סוד ההבדלה
להבדיל בין אור לחשך ונגה
באור תהיה. עוד ישים האדם
אל לבו בקריאתו פסוקים אלו
ומגמת פניו יהיה להכניע החצוני
לבל יהיה לו חלק ואחיזה ככל
האפשר לו עמו בעת זווגו עם
אשתו ומה טוב לרווקים להקדים
להתפלל בהם לעת מצא זו אשה
על דרך שאמרו לעולם יקדים
אדם תפלה כי ודאי צריך ערמה
גדולה ותחבולה רבה להנצל
מפח יקוש בעת ההולדה סוב נא
אחי בעיניך תביט דברי הגאון
קורדואיר״ו מה דבר בזה אשר
הובא מבעל ראשית חכמה בפרק
ט״ו משער הקדושה דף ר״פ.

Writings, I left them in their proper order, arranged and organized in prophecy and divine inspiration, for in this way their power is enhanced to fulfill the desire of all who ask. For when they stand, they stand, and when they are lifted above the earth, the Ophanim (angelic wheels) are lifted opposite them, and the breath of the mouth brings forth the supernal breath.[1] Concerning this, Rabbi Zeira said in Shabbat, chapter 2, "Had I come only to hear this, it would have been enough." And every voice and voice has its own path, as we say in Bava Batra, first chapter. And the spirit of the supernal Chayot (living creatures) is in the Ophanim described, each man in his place in peace. And through this, one will merit each day to pour out his meditation in the counted number of 120 verses—sixty in the morning and sixty in the evening hours—to sweeten the 120 permutations of Elohim.[2] And he should intend to distinguish the three holy Elohim which are in Binah, Gevurah, and Malkhut, from other gods, God forbid. This is the secret of Havdalah (separation): "to separate between light and darkness," and "brightness shall be as light." Furthermore, a person should set his heart, when reciting these verses, and the aim of his countenance should be to subdue the external forces[A] so that they have no portion or hold with him, as much as possible, during his marital union with his wife. And how good it is for bachelors to preface this with prayer at the time of finding a wife, as they said, "A person should always preface with prayer," for certainly great wisdom and much strategy are needed to be saved from the snare at the time of procreation. Please, my brother, look with your eyes at the words of the Gaon Cordovero, what he spoke about this, which was brought by the author of Reishit Chochmah in chapter 16 of the Gate of Holiness, page 280. And the thoughts of the heart of one who recites these verses, besides what is required

[A] Or: "and his intention should be to subdue the external forces" — This simpler translation may be clearer for readers unfamiliar with the poetic Hebrew expression, though it loses some of the imagery of directing one's face/concentration toward a spiritual goal.

[1] This describes the kabbalistic understanding that human speech, particularly when reciting sacred texts, activates corresponding spiritual forces in higher realms.

[2] The number 120 has special significance, corresponding to Moses' lifespan, and in this context to the complete set of possible permutations of the divine name associated with judgment.

[i] The 120 permutations of the divine name Elohim. In kabbalah, this name is associated with judgment, and its permutations represent different aspects of divine justice that can be 'sweetened' through proper spiritual practice.

ועשתונות לב הקורא פסוקים
אלו מלבד הנדרש בהם יכוין
לאשורו להבדיל הרעה ממנו
100 ומאשתו בעת הזווג וכזה וכזו
יכוין גם כן בסדר הבדלתו
במוצאי שבתות ובימים טובים
וכן בכל מצוה ויחוד וקדושה
וכמו כן במה שאין בה אלא
105 מצות פרוש מדבריהם ובזה
צדק ילין בתוכם ושפחה בישא
עליה תרנה אשפה להב חנית
וכידון[i] וכבר אמרו בתקונים דף
כ״א שהזווג דומה ליחוד שאדם
110 עושה בתפלת י״ח בחשאי ולכך
עקר הכל שיהיה מעשה חשאי
זה בצניעות וכסוי ושלא לאור
הנר בשום אופן ואמרו דאיש
ואשתו המתקדשים והמטהרים
115 אינון דוגמא ארבעת אנפין הוי״ה
בארבע גדפין אדנ״י בחבורא
חדא שהם שמנה אותיות משולבים
כנודע ובזה יזכה האדם לנפש
חי״ה: [ii]

of them, should be directed properly to separate evil from himself and from his wife during marital union. And in this manner he should also direct his intention in the order of his Havdalah at the conclusion of Sabbaths and festivals, and likewise in every commandment, unification, and sanctification, and similarly in that which contains only the rabbinical commandment of separation. Through this, righteousness will abide within them, and the evil maidservant will wail over it,[1] quiver of the blade of spear and javelin. And they already said in Tikkunim, page 21, that marital union is similar to the unification that a person makes in the silent Amidah prayer, and therefore the essence of everything is that this private act should be in modesty and covering, and not by the light of a candle in any way. And they said that a man and his wife who sanctify and purify themselves are like the four faces of the Tetragrammaton with the four wings of Adonai in one joining, which are eight interwoven letters, as is known.[2] And through this, a person will merit a living soul.

פרק י״ג

Chapter 13

וייראו ממערב את שם ה׳
וממזרח שמש את כבודו כי משלם

From the west they shall fear the name of the LORD, and from the rising of the sun His glory, for He repays

[1] This uses poetic imagery from kabbalistic literature contrasting the divine feminine presence (righteousness) with negative spiritual forces (the evil maidservant), depicting spiritual victory through proper practice.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic practice of combining and interweaving the letters of the divine names YHVH and ADNY (totaling eight letters) to create a unified spiritual force, symbolically paralleling the unification of male and female in sanctified marital relations.

[i] A poetic metaphor depicting the 'evil maidservant' (representing negative spiritual forces) wailing over weapons that have become ineffective. This imagery suggests that proper spiritual practice renders harmful forces powerless.

[ii] Cf. Five afflictions of Yom Kippur — The text refers to the traditional five prohibitions on Yom Kippur (eating/drinking, washing, anointing, wearing leather shoes, and marital relations) as a parallel to the five types of judgment that can be sweetened through proper spiritual practice. | Cf. Rabbi Akiva's teaching about song — The author cites Rabbi Akiva's teaching that one who studies Torah with joyful song in this world will merit songs in the World to Come, emphasizing the spiritual rewards of daily scriptural study. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's structured collection of verses — The author references the structured collections of verses (60 in the morning, 60 in the evening) which he has compiled earlier in the work, explaining their kabbalistic significance in sweetening divine judgments. | Cf. Reishit Chochmah by Rabbi Eliyahu de Vidas — The author refers readers to Rabbi Moses Cordovero's teachings on marital sanctity as quoted in Reishit Chochmah, connecting his own teachings to established kabbalistic authorities on the subject of proper intentions during marital relations. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author cites the Tikkunei Zohar's comparison between marital union and the silent Amidah prayer, emphasizing that both are sacred unifications requiring proper intention, modesty, and sanctity.

חמה לצריו גמול לאויביו וכובע
ישועה בראשו לקרבת אלהים
יחפצון. הנה בל״ב נתיבות
פליאות חכמה ברא יה ה׳ צבאות
את עולמו ומהם יורדים ש״כ
ניצוצי גבוראן כי עשרה פעמים
ל״ב הם ש״ך ומז״א באים לשם
א״ד שהיא נוקביה דזעיר וכן
שם א״ד ה׳ פעמים עולה שכ״ה.
ועוד יש דין אחר יורד מאימא
לגבורה ומשם לכ״י והם פ״ד
ניצוצים כלולים בחמש גבורן
שהם מנצפ״ך שעולה פ״ר ועם
ה׳ אותיות עולים פר״ה אדומה
פירוש הדינים שבאים מהאדום.
ופעמים הפ״ר דינים נכפלים
והם ב׳ פעמים פ״ר בגימטרי״א
קס״ת. שם אל שבי״ג מדות
בו תקון ג׳ עולמות של מארי
דינין. ועלמא קדמא״ה הוא
אלף אלפין מארי תריסין והב׳
נ״ז אלפין דרגין מארי דיבבא.
והג׳ צ״ו אלפין מארי דיללה.
וכן במדות יש ג׳ שמות אלהים
כנזכר בפרק הקודם אחד בבינה
ואחד בגבורה ואחד במלכות
ואלהים במלואו ורבועו עולה
אלף ולכן נקט אלף לכל אחד
מהם והראשון שבבי״ע כולל
שנים האחרים ומספר אלף אלפין
ירצה האלף הראשון לעולם של
מעלה דהיינו של בינה עצמה

wrath to His adversaries and recompense to His enemies, with a helmet of salvation on His head; those who desire closeness to God. 5R

Behold, with thirty-two wondrous paths of wisdom[A] YAH, the LORD of Hosts created His world, and from them descend 320 sparks of strength, for ten times thirty-two equals 320. From Zeir Anpin these come to the name AD,[1] which 10R is the feminine aspect of Zeir, and likewise the name AD multiplied by five equals 325. And there is yet another judgment that descends from Imma to Gevurah and from there to Keter-Yesod, comprising 84 sparks included in the five powers 15R of judgment,[2] which are the five final letters MaNTzaPaKh that equal 280, and with the five letters themselves they total 285, which is "red heifer," meaning the judgments that come from the re[B]d. Sometimes these 280 judgments are doubled, 20R and twice 280 equals 560 in gematria.

The divine name El within the Thirteen Attributes serves to rectify three worlds of judgment-masters. The first world consists of one thousand thousands of shield-bearers;[C3] the second consists 25R of fifty-seven thousands of levels of wailing-masters; and the third consists of ninety-six thousands of howling-masters. Similarly, there are three divine names Elohim in the Attributes, as mentioned in the previous chapter: one in Binah, one in Gevurah, 30R and one in Malkhut. The name Elohim in its full spelling and squared form equals one thousand, and therefore he specified one thousand for each of them. The first [world] in Beriah-Yetzirah-Asiyah includes

[A] Or: "with thirty-two mysterious paths of wisdom" — The Hebrew term 'פליאות' can be translated as either 'wondrous' or 'mysterious'. While 'wondrous' captures the sense of awe, 'mysterious' might better convey the esoteric nature of these paths in kabbalistic tradition.

[B] Or: "red heifer, symbolizing judgments emanating from the red aspect" — This alternative emphasizes the symbolic rather than literal meaning and clarifies that 'the red' refers to a divine aspect (specifically Gevurah/Judgment) rather than just a color.

[C] Or: "masters of shields" — A more literal translation of the Aramaic term that preserves the construct form. Both translations are valid, but 'masters of shields' might better convey the hierarchical relationship implied in the original.

[1] The Hebrew abbreviation 'ז״א' refers to 'Zeir Anpin' (the Small-Faced One), a key concept in Lurianic Kabbalah representing the six sefirot from Chesed to Yesod as a unified divine configuration. The name 'א״ד' (AD) represents a divine name associated with the feminine aspect (Malkhut/Shekhinah).

[2] The term 'חמש גבורן' (five powers/judgments) refers to the five aspects of the divine attribute of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) corresponding to the five final Hebrew letters MaNTzaPaKh.

[3] The Hebrew terms 'מארי תריסין', 'מארי דיבבא', and 'מארי דיללה' (shield-bearers, wailing-masters, and howling-masters) are technical kabbalistic terms for different categories of angelic forces that execute divine judgment.

שהיא בריאה והב׳ אלפים לכללות יצירה ועשייה שבה. עלמא תניינא שבעה וחמשים אלפים דרגין דיבבא והוא נגד עולם היצירה שת״ת מקנן בה.

35R the other two, and the number "one thousand thousands" means the first thousand for the upper world, namely of Binah itself, which is Beriah, and the [other] two thousand for the entirety of Yetzirah and Asiyah within it.

וחשבון נ״ז הוא שם ההוי״ה שבת״ת ושם אל שהוא בכל עולם מהם לאכפיא הדינין כמ״ש באידרא שניהם יחד עולים נ״ז. עלמא תליתאה הוא צ״ו אלפים מארי דיללה זה מספר של עולם העשייה שמלכות מקננת בה ושם א״ד שבה ואל הוא התקון של כל אחד מהדינין אלו. ויחד עולים צ״ו ושם אלהים מתחלק לק״כ צרופים כפי הקדמת משנת ספר יצירה ה׳ אותיות בונות וכו׳. וכתיב בשלמה הנה מטתו ששים גבורים הנה עולה ששים כי הוא היה מכוין לחלק הק״כ אלהים הידועים ששים לבדם וששים לבדם שלא יהיה להם כ״כ התעוררות ולרמז זה גם אנחנו תקננו ששים פסוקים לחוד וששים לחוד בבקר ובערב וכן יברכך יאר ישא בהם ששים אותיות ותנן שש מעלות במקואות ואינון שש צירופי יה״ו. ויש י״ב צרופים של הוי״ה וי״ב צרופים של אלהים וי״ב של הוי״ה ממתקים הי״ב של אלהים כי כל אחד מצרופי אלהים כולל עשר מצרופיו וא״כ כל הוי״ה ממתקת עשר צרופי אלהים והנה י״ב הויו״ת ממתקים ק״כ צרופי אלהים ומתמתקים בכח מלוי שם ע״ב. שהוא הוי״ה ביודי״ן שבהסיר עקר ההוי״ה שהוא כ״ו ישאר מ״ו כי מעולם החסדים וכן הגבורות אינם נותנים מהעקר אלא מהמלוי. ושם אלהים שביודי״ן פירוש

40R The second world comprises fifty-seven thousand levels of wailing, corresponding to the world of Yetzirah where Tiferet nests.[1] The numerical value 57 is the sum of the divine name YHVH in Tiferet and the name El, which exists in each of these worlds to subdue the judgments, as stated in the Idra. Together they equal 57. The third world consists of ninety-six thousand howling-masters, which is the number of the world of Asiyah where Malkhut nests, along with the name AD within it. El is the rectification of each of these judgments, and together they equal 96.

55R The name Elohim divides into 120 permutations according to the introduction of Sefer Yetzirah: "Five letters build..." etc. Concerning Solomon it is written, "Behold his bed, surrounded by sixty mighty men."[2] "Behold" equals sixty, because he intended to divide the known 120 [permutations of] Elohim into sixty by themselves and sixty by themselves, so they would not have so much arousal. To allude to this, we too have arranged sixty verses separately in the morning and sixty separately in the evening. Likewise, [the priestly blessing] "May He bless you," "May He shine," "May He lift" contains sixty letters. And we have learned there are six levels in ritual baths, corresponding to the six permutations of YHV.[3]

70R There are twelve permutations of YHVH and twelve permutations of Elohim, and the twelve [permutations] of YHVH sweeten the twelve of Elohim. For each permutation of Elohim includes ten of its permutations, thus each YHVH sweetens ten permutations of Elohim. So twelve YHVHs sweeten 120 permutations of Elohim, and they are sweetened through the power of the full spelling of the 72-Name, which is YHVH spelled with Yuds.

[1] The phrase 'ת״ת מקנן בה' uses the metaphor of 'nesting' to describe how the divine attributes (sefirot) manifest within different spiritual worlds. This imagery comes from the Zohar and Tikkunei Zohar.

[2] The Hebrew doesn't exactly match the biblical text of Song of Songs 3:7 but paraphrases it. I've provided a translation that conveys the intended reference while acknowledging the variation.

[3] The Hebrew letters Yud-Heh-Vav (יה״ו) can be arranged in six different ways, and these permutations are considered to have spiritual significance corresponding to the six levels of ritual purity in Mishnah Mikvaot.

שהה״א היא ביו״ד כזה ה״י
ממתק בסוד כ״ו שהוא הוי״ה
ומתלבש ביו״ד של מטטרו״ן
המנהיג העולם ויש אלהים
בההי״ן כפול פשוט משולש
מרובע. שהם מ״א אותיות וי״ה
שהוא בבינה והוי״ה שהוא בת״ת
שלה שעולים מ״א ממתקים המ״א
אותיות של אלהים שהוא דין וזה
נקרא אחורים של אלהים והם
כתרים בפני הפורענות המנגדים
הקליפות המביאות האדם לידי
מחשבות רעות ועבירות ר״ל וכן
אלהים בגימטרי״א כו״ס ומיתוק
הק״כ צרופים נאמר כוס ישועות
אשא ואז בשם ה׳ אקרא כי ה׳
הוא האלהים והאלהים הוא ה׳
ושני דודים ממתקים ובחיותם
תואמים מלמטה יחדו הם תמים
אל ראשו להחיות רוח שפלים
ולב נדכאים אשר כל היום וכל
הלילה תמיד לא יחשו המזכירים
את ה׳. ואל דמי להם בשירי
חדש בפסוקי דזמרה לאלהינו
ושמחת עולם תהיה להם כי בית
תפארתו יפארו: [i]

When the root of YHVH, which is 26, is removed, 46 remains, for [it comes] from the world of kindnesses; similarly, the powers of judgment do not give from the root but from the full spelling.

The name Elohim spelled with Yuds (meaning the Heh is spelled with Yud, like this: HY) is sweetened through the mystery of 26, which is YHVH, and clothes itself in the Yud of Metatron who governs the world. There is also Elohim with Hehs, doubled, simple, tripled, and squared, comprising 41 letters. The divine names YH in Binah and YHVH in its Tiferet, which together equal 41, sweeten the 41 letters of Elohim, which is judgment. This is called the "back" of Eloh[1]im, and they serve as a shield against calamity,[A] opposing the negative forces that bring a person to evil thoughts and sins, God forbid. Similarly, Elohim in gematria equals KOS [cup], and concerning the sweetening of the 120 permutations it is said, "I will lift up the cup of salvation," and then "I will call upon the name of the LORD," for "the LORD is Elohim and Elohim is the LORD." The two beloved ones sweeten each other,[2] and when they are paired from below, they are perfect at its head, reviving the spirit of the lowly and the heart of the contrite,[B] who throughout the day and night are never silent, those who invoke the LORD.[3] Give

[A] Or: "as a protective barrier against punishment" — The term 'כתרים' specifically refers to a small shield or buckler, and 'פורענות' can more specifically mean divine punishment rather than general calamity. This alternative is more precise though less elegant.

[B] Or: "to give life to the spirit of the humble and the heart of the broken" — This alternative captures the same meaning but with slightly different nuances of the Hebrew terms 'שפלים' (lowly/humble) and 'נדכאים' (contrite/broken). Both are valid translations of this biblical allusion to Isaiah 57:15.

[1] The concept of 'אחורים' (back/posterior) in Kabbalah refers to the external aspect of a divine name, often associated with judgment, as opposed to the 'פנים' (face/interior) which represents mercy. This term has complex meanings in different kabbalistic systems.

[2] The phrase 'שני דודים ממתקים' uses the terminology of lovers from Song of Songs to describe the relationship between divine names or attributes. The 'sweetening' (מיתוק) of judgments is a central concept in Kabbalah, referring to the transformation of harsh judgment into mercy.

[3] This phrase alludes to Isaiah 62:6-7, which refers to watchmen on Jerusalem's walls who give the

[i] Cf. Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) — The text cites Sefer Yetzirah's teaching about the 32 paths of wisdom as the basis for its mystical numerology, establishing divine creation as operating through specific numerical and letter combinations. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:7 — The text reinterprets this verse kabbalistically, seeing the sixty warriors as representing Solomon's mystical ability to divide and control the 120 permutations of the divine name Elohim. | Cf. Idra Rabba (Great Assembly) — The text references the Idra's teachings about divine names and their power to subdue judgments, showing how the author integrates Zoharic concepts into his mystical system. | Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — The text notes that these three verses contain sixty letters total, connecting this biblical blessing to the mystical system of sixty-fold divisions that control divine judgment. | Cf. Psalm 116:13 — The verse is reinterpreted kabbalistically, with the 'cup' (KOS) being connected through gematria to the divine name Elohim, suggesting that ritual acts can 'sweeten' or transform divine judgment.

them no rest, with new songs in the verses of praise to our God, and eternal joy shall be theirs, for they shall adorn His house of glory.

פרק י״ד

Chapter 14

להיות האדם בנוי ומשוכלל בדוגמא העליונה אשר הוא קדוש ומשרתיו טהורים יזהר גם הוא להיות טהור בגופו ובאבריו באשר הוכחנו בח״ב מזה המעבר יבק כי בזה גורם לאכפיא רוחא דמסאבא[i] בנדרש בפ׳ תרומה דף קנ״ה. ברם הטהרה האמיתית היא טהרת הנפש לקבוע עתים לתורה ביום ובלילה ולא ישנה תפקידתו אפי׳ יהיה סבור להרויח ממון הרבה באותה שעה שהיא מטהרת הדבקים בה טהרה גמורה ומשיבה את הנפש לחוטא כדכתיב תורת ה׳ תמימה משיבת נפש. ויסמוך תורתו לתפלתו ליחד תפלה מלכות בתורה תפארת[ii] שאחר שנתקנה בתקוניה ומזדמנת לקראת בעלה צריך להמשיך

Since a person is built and perfected in the supernal image,[A] where He is holy and His attendants are pure, one should also be careful to maintain purity in one's body and limbs,[1] as we have proven in Part 2 of this Ma'avar Yabok, for this causes the suppression of the spirit of impurity,[B] as expounded in Parashat Terumah, page 155. However, true purification is the purification of the soul by establishing fixed times for Torah study day and night. One should not change this appointed schedule even if one thinks one could earn much money during that time, for Torah purifies those who cleave to it with complete purification and restores the soul of the sinner, as it is written, "The Torah of the LORD is perfect, restoring the soul."

One should connect one's Torah study to one's prayer, thereby unifying prayer (which corresponds to Malkhut) with Torah (which corresponds to Tiferet).[2] For after she [Malkhut] has been prepared with her adornments and readies herself to meet her husband, one must draw her husband, Tiferet, to her

[A] Or: "As the human being is constructed and perfected according to the supernal pattern" — This alternate translation emphasizes the concept of humans being 'patterned' after divine structures rather than simply being an 'image,' which better conveys the kabbalistic concept that human form mirrors cosmic structures.

[B] Or: "for through this one causes the subjugation of the spirit of impurity" — The Aramaic term 'אכפיא' has the specific technical meaning in Kabbalah of 'subjugation' or 'forcing down,' which is slightly stronger than 'suppression' and better conveys the active spiritual warfare implied in the text.

LORD no rest. The author adapts this to describe those who continually recite divine names and praises.

[1] The concept of bodily purity here goes beyond basic hygiene to include ritual purity according to Jewish law (taharat ha-guf), and is connected to the belief that the physical body is a vessel for divine energies.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic view that human religious activities create cosmic effects, specifically the unification of divine attributes. Prayer is associated with Malkhut (the divine feminine), while Torah study connects to Tiferet (the central masculine attribute), and their unification represents cosmic harmony.

[i] This Aramaic phrase from the Zohar refers to the spiritual practice of subjugating or forcing down the 'spirit of impurity'—negative spiritual forces that can attach themselves to a person through ritual impurity or sin.

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic concept of unifying divine attributes through human actions. Prayer corresponds to Malkhut (the divine feminine/Kingdom), while Torah study corresponds to Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony, the central divine masculine attribute). Their unification represents cosmic repair.

לה בעלה ת״ח ע״י יסוד וסוד
אותיות התורה המרובעות הוא
שפע הבינה[i] שבה ארבע יסודות
ומה מאד מסוגל לקרא פסוקי
הפרשה עם התרגום למתוק
קליפת נגה[ii] בנזכר למעלה
אחר התפלה מיד וכל העוסק
בתורה בעה״ז זוכה לאשתדלא
בה לעלמא דאתי[iii] עיין בחלק
דף קפ״ה ויערב לך. [iv]

through Yesod.[1] The secret of the square-shaped letters of the Torah represents the flow from Binah, which contains the four elements.[A] It is especially beneficial to read the weekly Torah portion with its Aramaic translation immediately after prayer to sweeten the kelipat nogah[2] (the luminous shell), as mentioned above. And whoever engages in Torah study in this world merits to delve into it in the World to Come, as explained in the Zohar, page 185, and it will be pleasing to you.

וילמד תורה לבניו דשכרו
גדול ואם אינו יכול ידבק
בלומדיה ויחזיקם דכתיב עץ
חיים היא למחזיקים בה. ותמכיה
מאושר.[v] וכתוב בזהר פ׳
וישלח דף קע״א ומאן דלעי
באורייתא ולית מאן דסמיך
ליה ולא אשתכח מאן דאטיל
מלאי לביסתיה לאתקפא. על
דא אורייתא משתכחא בכל

He should teach Torah to his sons, for the reward is great, and if he cannot, he should cleave to those who study and support them, as it is written, "It is a tree of life for those who grasp it, and its supporters are fortunate." It is written in the Zohar, Parashat Vayishlach, page 171: "One who engages in Torah study but has no one to support him, and there is no one found who puts provisions in his purse to strengthen him—because of this, Torah is found in every generation, but the strength of Torah

[A] Or: "The mystical significance of the Torah's square letters is the divine influx from Binah, in which are contained the four elemental foundations" — This alternative more explicitly conveys the kabbalistic concept that the physical shape of Hebrew letters contains cosmic significance, and clarifies that 'יסודות' refers specifically to the four primordial elements (earth, air, fire, water) which are foundational in kabbalistic cosmology.

[1] In the kabbalistic structure of divine attributes (sefirot), Yesod (Foundation) is the channel that connects Tiferet to Malkhut, transmitting divine flow between them. This is often associated with the phallus in anthropomorphic descriptions of the divine structure.

[2] In Lurianic Kabbalah, 'sweetening' (מיתוק) refers to the process of transforming potentially negative spiritual forces into positive ones. Kelipat nogah is unique among the 'shells' or 'husks' that conceal divinity because it contains a mixture of good and evil and can be elevated through proper ritual actions.

[i] The square shape of Hebrew letters is seen as cosmically significant in Kabbalah. The 'squareness' represents stability and perfection, and is understood to channel divine influx from Binah (Understanding), the third and feminine aspect of the intellect in the divine emanations.

[ii] Kelipat nogah (the 'luminous shell') is a unique category in Lurianic Kabbalah—a neutral spiritual force that can be elevated to holiness or degraded to impurity. 'Sweetening' it refers to the mystical process of transforming and elevating it to holiness.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase expresses the kabbalistic belief that Torah study in the afterlife continues at a higher level for those who devoted themselves to it in this world, suggesting a continuity between intellectual endeavors in this world and the next.

[iv] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — The author cites this Zohar passage to establish textual authority for the claim that bodily purity has cosmic effects in suppressing negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Psalms 19:8 — The verse is used to support the claim that Torah study has transformative effects on the soul, particularly for repentant sinners. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part 2 — The author references his own earlier discussion of bodily purity, creating internal continuity between the sections of the book and showing how these discourses build on each other. | Cf. Zohar — This reference reinforces the eternal value of Torah study, suggesting that intellectual and spiritual achievements in this world create corresponding realities in the afterlife.

[v] This quote is from Proverbs 3:18, continuing the metaphor of Torah as a 'tree of life' and emphasizing that those who support Torah scholars are 'fortunate' or 'blessed.'

דרא ודרא ואתחלש תוקפא
דאורייתא כל יומא ויומא וכו׳
ואמר עוד וכד אינון סמכין
חלשין גרמין לאתקפא ההוא
דלית ליה שוקין ורגלין לקיימא
עלייהו שהוא כח הנחש הקדמוני
ונחש עקלתון.[i] ובשבת פרק ט״ז
אמר לא חרבה ירושלים אלא
בשביל שבזו בה תלמידי חכמים
שנאמר ויהיו מלעיבים במלאכי
אלהים.[ii] ועון זה ג״כ גורם כי
ישראל היו גולים ממקומם כמה
דתנינן בירו׳ דחגיגה ובכמה
מקומות בגמרין תני רשב״י אם
ראית עיירות שנתלשו ממקומן
בארץ ישראל דע שלא החזיקו
בשכר סופרים ומשנים מ״ט על
מה אבדה הארץ וגו׳ ויאמר ה׳
על עזבם את תורתי[iii] וספריא
ומתניא אינון נטורי קרתא
וויתר הקב״ה וכו׳ ולא וויתר על
ביטול תורה ומאיסתא בה ואמרו
בירו׳ פרק אלו נאמרים עתיד
הקב״ה לעשות צל לבעלי מצות
בצלן של בעלי תורה דכתיב כי
בצל החכמה בצל הכסף ואומר
עץ חיים היא למחזיקים בה
ואמרו בירו׳ דמכות על יואב
דכתיב ביה ויקבר בביתו במדבר
אין תימא שהיה בוזז ומאכיל
חכמים ותלמידיהם שבח שבחים
זה לו שלבן במותו נעשו ישראל
כמדבר[iv] ובמדרש שיר השירים
ואמרו מה אגוז זה משמר את
פריו כך עמי הארץ שבישראל
עליהם להחזיק בדברי תורה ואז
זוכה ויושב בישיבה של מעלה
כדאמרי׳ בפסחים פרק מקום

weakens every day." And it says further, "When these supports are weak, they cause to be strengthened that which has no legs or feet to stand upon," which is the power of the primordial serpent and the twisted serpent. And in Shabbat, chapter 16, it says: "Jerusalem was destroyed only because they despised the Torah scholars in it, as it is said: 'They mocked the messengers of God.'" This sin also causes Israel to be exiled from their place, as we learn in the Jerusalem Talmud of Hagigah and in several places in our Gemara. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai taught: "If you see towns uprooted from their place in the Land of Israel, know that they did not support the scribes and teachers. Why? 'For what reason did the land perish?' 'And the Lord said, because they have forsaken My Torah.'" And the scribes and teachers are the guardians of the city, and the Holy One, blessed be He, forgave, etc., but He did not forgive the neglect of Torah and contempt for it. They said in the Jerusalem Talmud, chapter "These Are Recited": "In the future, the Holy One, blessed be He, will make a shadow for those who perform commandments in the shadow of those who study Torah, as it is written: 'For in the shadow of wisdom is the shadow of money,' and it says: 'It is a tree of life for those who grasp it.'" And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud of Makkot regarding Joab, about whom it is written: "And he was buried in his house in the wilderness"—if you suggest that he would plunder and feed Torah scholars and their students, this is praise for him, for at his death, Israel became like a wilderness. And in the Midrash on the Song of Songs, they said: "Just as this nut preserves its fruit, so the common people of Israel must support the words of Torah," and then one merits to sit in the heavenly academy,[1] as we say in Pesachim, chapter "The Place Where They Practiced," regarding Shimon, the brother of Azariah.

[1] This reflects the Jewish belief that those who support Torah scholars share in their heavenly reward, with the ultimate honor being participation in the celestial academy or yeshiva.

[i] This is a metaphorical reference to evil forces or the 'Other Side' (Sitra Achra) in kabbalistic terminology. The primordial serpent represents the original tempter in Eden, while the 'twisted serpent' (nachash akalaton) appears in Isaiah 27:1 as a symbol of cosmic evil.

[ii] From 2 Chronicles 36:16, describing how the people mocked God's messengers (understood here as Torah scholars) before the destruction of the First Temple.

[iii] From Jeremiah 9:12, where God explains the reason for the land's destruction.

[iv] The text is interpreting the verse about Joab's burial (1 Kings 2:34) to suggest that the reference to 'wilderness' indicates that after Joab's death, Israel became desolate like a wilderness because he had been supporting Torah scholars.

שנהגו בשמעון אחי עזריה.[i] ואי
80 לא דמסתפינא אמינא כי עון זה
הנמצא בינינו שלא להחזיק ידי
לומדי תורה הוא גרמא בנזקין
כי שכחת התורה בעונות נראית
יותר בגלילות איטליאה מכל
85 שאר מחוזות[ii] לא כן בארצות
המערב וגם לא בארץ אשכנז כי
יש שם ישיבות יושבי על מדין
ומלמדים תורה ברבים ישמרם
ה׳ ויעלם גם עלה אבל במחוז
90 הלז וידל ישראל מאד וזה לפי
שאנשי חסד נאספים וכובשים
פניהם בקרקע ואינם מספקין
לת״ח אך מדחים אותם מעליהם
הרבה מהם. ומי שיש לו בת והוא
95 אמוד בנכסים מבקש להשיא
אותם עם בן עשיר מיד נותן עיניו
בממון ומשיא בתו לממון לא
לאיש כי אינו משגיח אם הוא בור
וגולם ואפי׳ אם לא תהיה יראת
100 ה׳ על פניו אומר ימים ידברו
בו וישוב מדרכו ומרגלא בפיהם
הממון מכסה הבושת.[iii] ובת
ת״ח עני תשב עד שתלבין ראשה
לא כן עושים בארץ אשכנז
105 וגלילותיה כי משיאים בנותיהם
לת״ח ולמשפחות מיוחסות ומי
שחננו ה׳ זהב וכסף ויש לו

And if I were not afraid, I would say[A] that this sin
found among us—not supporting the hands of Torah 80R
scholars—is the cause of damages, for the forgetting
of Torah due to sins is more evident in the regions
of Italy than in all other provinces.[1] It is not so in
the lands of the West, nor in the land of Ashkenaz,
for there are academies there with those who sit in 85R
judgment and teach Torah publicly—may God pro-
tect them and elevate them ever higher. But in this
province, Israel has become very impoverished, and
this is because compassionate people are gathered
and bury their faces in the ground,[B] and they do not 90R
provide for Torah scholars, but rather, many of them
push them away. And one who has a daughter and
is wealthy seeks to marry her to a rich man's son—
immediately he sets his eyes on money and marries
his daughter to money, not to a man, for he does 95R
not care if the man is ignorant and uncultured, and
even if the fear of God is not upon his face,[C] he says,
"Days will speak to him, and he will turn from his
ways." And it is common in their mouths to say,
"Money covers shame." And the daughter of a poor 100R
Torah scholar sits until her head turns white.

They do not act this way in the land of Ashkenaz
and its regions, for they marry their daughters to
Torah scholars and to distinguished families. And
one who has been blessed by God with gold and sil- 105R
ver and has a daughter to marry goes to the head
of the academy so that he will choose for him one of

[A] Or: "were I not apprehensive, I would declare" — This is a rabbinic expression indicating that the author is about to make a bold or potentially controversial statement. An alternate translation might better capture the formal rhetorical nature of this expression.

[B] Or: "and bow their faces to the ground" — This metaphorical expression could refer to people who are ashamed or unwilling to face a problem directly. The alternate translation preserves the image while being slightly less literal.

[C] Or: "and even if he shows no reverence for God" — This idiomatic expression refers to piety and religious observance. The alternate translation conveys the meaning in more contemporary English.

[1] This passage provides important historical context about the state of Torah scholarship in early modern Italy as perceived by the author. He is drawing a contrast between Italy, where he sees Torah learning declining, and the Ashkenazi communities (Germany and Eastern Europe), which he views as having stronger support systems for scholars.

[i] This refers to a Talmudic discussion (Pesachim 49b) about Shimon who was supported by his brother Azariah so he could study Torah. The Talmud credits Shimon's Torah as belonging partly to Azariah, showing the merit of supporting Torah scholars.

[ii] This reflects the author's perspective on the decline of Torah study in Italy compared to other Jewish communities. This is significant historical evidence of the author's view of Italian Jewish culture in his time.

[iii] A saying that appears to have been common in the author's time, suggesting that wealth can cover up or compensate for shameful qualities in a potential son-in-law.

בת להשיאה הולך אצל ראש
ישיבה למען יברור לו אחד מן
התלמידים הגונים ושמובטח בו
שיורה הוראות בישראל ואליו
הוא נושא נפשו ומהנהו ומרוממו
ובזה הם מעמידים תורה
בארמנותם לא כאלו הכופתים
בנותיהם ונותנן אותן לפני ארי
המכים ובועלין ואין להם בושת
פנים על זה ידוו כל הדווים
איך נהיתה הרעה הזאת בארצות
אלו ובזה חכמת סופרים תסרח
ואנשי חיל מתמעטים ועל מי יש
לנו להסמך אם לא על אבינו
שבשמים שיראה ויפקוד גפן זאת
וישים העקוב למישור. [i]

the worthy students who is assured to teach rulings in Israel, and to him he lifts his soul and benefits him and elevates him. In this way, they establish Torah in their palaces, not like those who bind their daughters and give them before lions[1] who strike and have sexual relations with them and have no shame. For this, let all who grieve, grieve—how has this evil happened in these lands? Because of this, the wisdom of scribes rots, and men of valor decrease,[2] and upon whom do we have to rely if not upon our Father in heaven, who will see and visit this vine and make the crooked straight.[3]

110R 115R

ע״כ כל בעל נפש יחוש לעצמו
להדבק בטובים ולישא בת
ת״ח. [ii] ואמרו ביומא פ״ז אם
רואה אדם שתורה פוסקת
מזרעו ישא בת ת״ח שנאמר
אם יזקין בארץ שרשו וגו׳
מריח מים יפריח ואין מים אלא
תורה [iii] שנאמר וגו׳ ובקדושין
פ״ק כל הנושא אשה שאינה הוגנת
לו אליהו מכריז עליו אוי לו

Therefore, every spiritual person should be concerned for himself to cleave to good people and to marry the daughter of a Torah scholar. They said in Yoma (Chapter 7): If a person sees that Torah is ceasing from his offspring, he should marry the daughter of a Torah scholar, as it is said, “Though its root grows old in the earth [and its stump dies in the ground, at the scent of water it will bud and put forth branches like a young plant]” (Job 14:8-9). And “water” refers only to Torah, as it is

120R 125R

[1] This is a harsh metaphorical criticism of Italian Jewish families who marry their daughters to wealthy but unlearned men. The author portrays these uneducated husbands as dangerous ‘lions’ who will harm their wives spiritually if not physically.

[2] The term ‘men of valor’ (anshei chayil) refers to accomplished Torah scholars rather than physical warriors, continuing the author’s lament about the decline of scholarship in his community.

[3] The passage concludes with a plea to God using biblical language that echoes Isaiah 40:4, expressing hope that divine intervention will correct the social problems the author has described.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayishlach — The author quotes this Zohar passage to establish his theological argument that inadequate support for Torah scholars doesn’t merely neglect a positive duty but actively empowers negative spiritual forces. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Hagigah — The author cites rabbinic precedent connecting the physical destruction of communities with their failure to support Torah scholarship, reinforcing his argument about Italian Jewish communities. | Cf. Midrash on Song of Songs — This reference uses natural imagery to argue that just as a shell protects the fruit, the laity (non-scholars) should protect and support scholars for the spiritual health of the community. | Cf. Talmud Pesachim — The author invokes this classic Talmudic example of a scholar supported by his merchant brother, where both received credit for the Torah learning, to emphasize the spiritual benefits that accrue to those who support scholars.

[ii] The recommendation to marry a daughter of a Torah scholar is a recurring theme in rabbinic literature, based on the belief that Torah learning and righteousness can be transmitted through family lineage, especially maternal influence.

[iii] This is interpreting the verse from Job 14:8-9 metaphorically. The full verse describes a tree that, though appearing dead, will sprout at the scent of water. The metaphorical reading identifies ‘water’ as Torah, drawing on the common rabbinic metaphor of Torah as water, based on Isaiah 55:1.

לפוסל את זרעו ולפוגם את
משפחתו והקב״ה חותם ובפ׳
עשרה יוחסין אמרו כל הנושא
וכו׳ אליהו כופתו והקב״ה
רוצעו.[i] ובבתרא פ״ח אמרו
לעולם ידבק אדם בטובים שהרי
משה שנשא בת יתרו וכו׳ וכתוב
בהגהות סי׳ ב׳ מא״ה בהגה״ה
המתחלת כל הנושא אשה פסולה
משום ממון הווין לו בנים שאינם
מהוגנים כתב בסוף כל מי שפסקו
לו ממון הרבה לשדוכין וחזרו
בהם לא יעגן כלתו משום זה ולא
יתקוטט בעבור נכסי אשתו ומי
שעושה כן אינו מצליח ואין זווגו
עולה יפה כי הממון שאדם לוקח
עם אשתו אינו ממון של יושר וכל
העושה כן מקרי נושא אשה לשם
ממון[ii] אלא כל מה שיתן לו חמיו
וחמותו יקח בעין טוב ואז יצליח
ובראש סי׳ ל״ב בפל דבריו
בדין הפוסק מעות לחתנו ומשל
העולם בזה הוא כדבריו ודאי.
גם בפסחים פ״ג אמרו לעולם
ישא אדם בת ת״ח שאם מת או
גולה מובטח לו שבניו ת״ח דבת
ת״ח פקדונא דמריה אתמסר
בידה[iii] כדאמרי׳ בזהר. ואשה
טובה מתנה טובה. ובמדרש רבה
אמרו שהכל מן האשה להיות
האדם צדיק. ובהוריות פ״ב
אמרו כי הונא בר רב נחמן פשט
בעיא אחת לרב פפא וקם נשקיה
ברישיה ויהיב ליה ברתיה.
והנושא בת ת״ח ומקדש עצמו
בשעת תשמיש[iv] וביום שלפניו
מרבה מצות ובגמילות חסדים
יותר משאר הימים ובכל כחו

stated [in Isaiah 55:1, "Ho, everyone who thirsts, come to the waters"]. And in Kiddushin (Chapter 1), [it says]: "Anyone who marries a woman who is not suitable for him, Elijah proclaims about him: 'Woe to him who disqualifies his offspring and blemishes his family,'" and the Holy One, blessed be He, seals it. And in Chapter "Ten Lineages" [of Tractate Kiddushin], they said: "Anyone who marries [an unsuitable woman], Elijah binds him and the Holy One, blessed be He, flogs him." And in Bava Batra (Chapter 8), they said: "A person should always cleave to good people, for behold, Moses married the daughter of Jethro," etc. And it is written in the glosses to Section 2 from Even HaEzer, in the gloss beginning with "Anyone who marries an unfit woman for the sake of money will have children who are not worthy," he wrote at the end: "Anyone for whom a large sum of money was promised for a match and then they retracted should not keep his bride waiting because of this, nor should he quarrel over his wife's property. One who does so will not succeed, and his marriage will not turn out well, for money that a man takes with his wife is not righteous money. Anyone who does so is called 'one who marries a woman for the sake of money.' Rather, whatever his father-in-law and mother-in-law give him, he should accept with a generous eye, and then he will succeed." And at the beginning of Section 32, he repeated his words concerning the case of one who promises money to his son-in-law, and the saying of the world in this matter is certainly according to his words. Also, in Pesachim (Chapter 3), they said: "A person should always marry the daughter of a Torah scholar, for if he dies or is exiled, it is assured that his children will be Torah scholars, for the daughter of a Torah scholar is entrusted with a deposit from her Master," as we say in the Zohar. And a good wife

130R 135R 140R 145R 150R 155R 160R 165R

[i] This graphic description uses violent imagery—binding and piercing the ear (as was done to a slave who chooses to remain with his master)—to emphasize the severity of divine disapproval for unsuitable marriages.

[ii] The text strongly condemns marrying for financial gain, reflecting the concern that materialistic motivations for marriage lead to spiritual and familial problems. This contrasts with the ideal marriage motivation being the creation of a spiritually elevated household.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase describes the daughter of a Torah scholar as having been entrusted with a divine deposit, suggesting she carries spiritual qualities directly from God that she will transmit to her children.

[iv] This refers to the kabbalistic practice of sanctifying marital relations through proper intentions, ritual preparations, and specific prayers. This practice was elaborated in many mystical works, including those influenced by the Safed kabbalists.

ומתודה בכל לבו. ומשכים אחר
ליל עונה לבית הכנסת ומבקש
רחמים כמו שנמצא כתוב בתקוני
175 התשובה. יזכה להמשיך לזרעו
אחריו נשמות קדושות ראויות
לזרע ברך ה׳.[i] [ii]

is a good gift.[1] And in Midrash Rabbah, they said that everything depends on the woman for a man to be righteous. And in Horayot (Chapter 2), they said 170R
that Huna bar Rav Nachman resolved a question for Rav Pappa, and [Rav Pappa] arose, kissed him on his head, and gave him his daughter. And one who marries the daughter of a Torah scholar and sanctifies himself at the time of sexual relations and 175R
on the day before,[2] increases in commandments and acts of kindness more than other days, with all his strength, and confesses with all his heart, and rises early after the night of the marital obligation[3] to the synagogue to ask for mercy, as is found written 180R
in the Rectifications of Repentance—he will merit to draw after him to his offspring holy souls[4] worthy of the seed blessed by God.

פרק ט״ו

Chapter 15

מי יאמר זכיתי לבי טהרתי
מחשבתי מחטאתי ובודאי
ראיתי בני עליה והנם

Who can say, "I have purified my heart; I have cleansed my thoughts from sin"? Indeed, I have seen those who ascend spiritually, and they are few—

[1] This is an allusion to Proverbs 18:22: 'He who finds a wife finds a good thing, and obtains favor from the LORD.'

[2] The text is describing spiritual preparations for marital intimacy, reflecting the kabbalistic understanding that proper intention and sanctification before and during marital relations affects the spiritual quality of children conceived from the union.

[3] This refers to prayer after fulfilling the mitzvah of conjugal relations, suggesting that prayer at this time has special efficacy for influencing the spiritual quality of potential offspring.

[4] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that parents' spiritual state and actions can 'attract' or 'draw down' higher-quality souls for their children, viewing conception not merely as a biological process but as a spiritual one involving the attraction of a pre-existing soul.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the spiritual state and intentions of the parents during conception directly affect the quality of the soul that will be drawn to the child. This concept is particularly developed in Lurianic Kabbalah.

[ii] Cf. Tractate Yoma, Chapter 7 — Used to support the recommendation to marry a Torah scholar's daughter to maintain Torah learning in one's family line | Cf. Tractate Kiddushin, Chapter 1 — Cites Elijah's proclamation against those who marry unsuitable women, emphasizing the importance of proper marriage choices | Cf. Tractate Kiddushin, Chapter 'Ten Lineages' — Reinforces the previous statement with more severe language of divine punishment | Cf. Tractate Bava Batra, Chapter 8 — Uses Moses as an exemplar of someone who married into a good family, despite Jethro being a convert | Cf. Even HaEzer, Section 2 — Warns against marrying for money and advises against quarreling over dowry amounts, suggesting this leads to unsuccessful marriages | Cf. Even HaEzer, Section 32 — Reinforces the previous point about financial expectations in marriage arrangements | Cf. Tractate Pesachim, Chapter 3 — Promises that such a marriage ensures one's children will be Torah scholars, even in difficult circumstances | Cf. Zohar — Adds a mystical dimension to the Talmudic recommendation by suggesting she carries a divine deposit | Cf. Midrash Rabbah — Emphasizes the wife's role in determining her husband's spiritual status | Cf. Tractate Horayot, Chapter 2 — Illustrates how Torah scholars valued intellectual accomplishment in potential sons-in-law | Cf. Tikkune haTeshuvah (Rectifications of Repentance) — Provides practical spiritual guidance for sanctifying the marital union to produce righteous children

מועטים המתקדשים והמטהרים
רעיונותיהם ועיילי בלא בר[i] ועל
טוהר המחשבה יתפלל כל חסיד
לה׳ וייחד לו בקשות ויחודים
לעתים הגונים כי דבר גדול
דברה אלינו התורה תמימה
בפסוק ולא תתורו אחרי לבבכם
ואפילו בדברי׳ הגשמיים והגסים
שבהן משכן הקליפות והחומר
אין ראוי לאדם להמשך אחריהם
שבהם נאחזים החצונים ומטמא
האדם עצמו. ולכן בהיותו
מתפלל צריך לעצום עיניו שלא
יביט בדברים הגשמיים ובעצימת
עינים יעלה בדעתו הדברים
הדקים ויתאחז ברוחני שהוא כח
החיוני הדק המתלבש בעולם
הגס הזה המתראים לנגד בתחלת
העלמתם ובהיותו מזכך הדברים
ומעלה אותם בסוד הדקות
אז הוא דק וזך דוגמת אחד
מצבאי המרום. ובשנמשך אחר
החומר ועוביות הדברים נקרא
זונה כדכתיב אשר אתם זונים
אחריהם כי האדם נברא להמשיך
אחר הדברים הדקים הנעלמים
בטבע נשמתו רוחו ונפשו אם
ימשך אחר עביותם נקרא זונה
כי יוצא ממדתו ואוי לו לבית
פי׳ גופו של אדם שהלפת עוברת
תמיד בתוכו[ii] וכל רוח דק
ימשך אחר הגבלת צורתו דרך
משל אם יחשוב האדם כל ימיו

those who sanctify and purify their thoughts[1] and enter without impurity. Every pious person should pray to the Lord for purity of thought and dedicate specific requests and unifications at appropriate times.[2] For the perfect Torah has spoken something profound to us in the verse "Do not follow after your hearts," even regarding physical and coarse matters in which the forces of impurity and materiality dwell. It is not proper for a person to be drawn after them, for in them the external forces take hold,[3] and a person defiles himself.

Therefore, when praying, one must close one's eyes so as not to look at physical things. With closed eyes, one will elevate in one's mind subtle matters and grasp the spiritual, which is the refined life-force clothed in this coarse world, appearing opposite at the beginning of their concealment. When one refines these matters and elevates them in the mystery of subtlety,[4] then one becomes refined and pure like one of the heavenly hosts. But when one is drawn after materiality and the coarseness of things, one is called a "harlot,"[5] as it is written, "after which you go astray." For humans were created to pursue the subtle, hidden things in accordance with the nature of their soul, spirit, and life-force. If one is drawn after coarseness, one is called a "harlot" because one departs from one's proper measure. Woe to the "house"—meaning a person's body—where the turnip is always passing through it, and every subtle spirit is drawn after the limitation of its form.

For example, if a person thinks all his days about the Holy Name, about the forms of its letters, its vowel points, its interpretations, and the appellations

5R 10R 15R 20R 25R 30R 35R

[1] This is an allusion to the Talmudic statement (Sukkah 45b) about the scarcity of "sons of ascent" (בני עליה), those who reach the highest spiritual levels.

[2] "Unifications" (יחודים) refers to kabbalistic meditative practices focused on uniting divine names and attributes. These were often reserved for specific times deemed spiritually auspicious.

[3] "External forces" (החצונים) is a kabbalistic term for negative spiritual entities that exist outside the realm of holiness, often associated with impurity and evil.

[4] This phrase (בסוד הדקות) refers to the kabbalistic concept that spiritual realities become increasingly subtle and refined as they ascend through the divine worlds.

[5] The term "harlot" (זונה) is being used metaphorically, based on the Hebrew root meaning "to stray." The text interprets the biblical prohibition against "straying after your hearts" as referring to inappropriate attachment to physical reality.

[i] This phrase is challenging to translate precisely. It literally means "entering without outside/foreign [elements]," but in context refers to entering into prayer or spiritual states without impure thoughts.

[ii] This is an unusual metaphor where the body is compared to a house through which a turnip (לפת) passes. This appears to be a reference to how physical food (represented by the turnip) continually passes through the body, symbolizing its material nature.

בשם הקדוש בצורות אותיותיו
ובנקודתו בפירושיו ובכנויי
כנויו ימשיך על עצמו רוח זך
40 אלהי ודאי. וטוב לזה להרגיל
האדם עצמו לומר בכל יום
מזמור קל״ה. ואם יחשוב תמיד
בדברים גשמיים. ימשיך על
עצמו תכונה רעה וזהו לדעתי
45 כוונת חז״ל ונתן עול ברזל על
צוארך זה טרדת רעיון[i] שכל
עוד שאינו חושב בקדושה הוא
נטרד ח״ו ובדד ישב מחוץ
למחנה קדושה מושבו שכמו
50 שמשכן הקדושה בשם הקדושה כן
משכן הקליפות בדברים חומרים
ותאות הגשמיות. וענין הקרי
יוכיח[ii] כי המהרהר עמל מוליד
און ושקר ברם שאר מחשבות
55 אינם קלות להפעל ופגם גדול
גורם המחשבה הרעה וזהו
הרהורי עבירה קשים מעבירה.
והנה בהולדת הבנים כמו שאדם
חושב כן ממש פועל וזה אומרו
60 ולא תתורו אחרי לבבכם וגו׳
ואמרו בגמרין אל תפנו אל
מדעתכם. ופי׳ בתקונים שזהו
סוד והאיש משה עניו מאד שהיה
מתבייש מקונו ואומר איך אחשוב
65 בדברים גשמיים והנה קוני יודע
יצר מחשבות לבי ואיך אחשוב
לפניו בדבר שיש לי בושת
לעשות מה לי עשייה ממש לפני
הבורא מה לי מחשבה הלא הכל
70 גלוי לפניו ויותר ידוע לפניו
המחשבה מהמעשה לפני ב״ו.
ואצ״ל כי האדם פועל במדות
העליונות ע״י הדברים הגשמיים
הנמצאים בעולם בהשתתף
75 כוונתו בהם ואמרו בתמיד פ״ק

of its epithets, he will surely draw upon himself a pure divine spirit. It is good for a person to accustom himself to recite Psalm 135 every day. But if one always thinks about physical matters, one will 40R
draw upon oneself an evil disposition. This, in my opinion, is the meaning of our Sages' statement, "He places an iron yoke upon your neck"—this refers to distraction of thought, for as long as one does not think in holiness, one is driven away, heaven forbid, 45R
and "he shall dwell alone; outside the camp shall be his dwelling." For just as the dwelling of holiness is in the holy name, so is the dwelling of the forces of impurity in material things and physical desires.

The matter of keri [nocturnal emission] proves 50R
this, for one who contemplates toil begets iniquity and falsehood. However, other thoughts are not easily actualized. Great damage is caused by evil thoughts, and this is why "thoughts of sin are worse than sin itself."[1] Indeed, in the begetting of children, 55R
a person actually effects what he thinks, and this is the meaning of "Do not follow after your hearts," and they said in the Gemara, "Do not turn to your own understanding."

It is explained in the Tikkunim[2] that this is the 60R
secret of "the man Moses was very humble," for he was embarrassed before his Creator and said, "How can I think about physical things when my Creator knows the inclination of my thoughts? How can I contemplate before Him something that I would be 65R
ashamed to do? What difference is there between actual deed before the Creator and thought? Is not everything revealed before Him? And thought is more known to Him than action is known to flesh and blood." 70R

It goes without saying that a person affects the supernal attributes through physical things found in the world when one's intention participates with them. They said in Tractate Tamid, first chapter, "What is the straight path that a person should 75R

[1] This is a reference to the Talmudic statement (Yoma 29a) that sinful thoughts can be more spiritually damaging than the actual commission of sins.
[2] This refers to Tikkunei Zohar, a section of the Zohar (the central text of Jewish mysticism) consisting of seventy interpretations of the first word of the Torah.

[i] The concept of "טרדת רעיון" (distraction of thought) is a technical term in Jewish mystical literature that refers to the mind being diverted from contemplation of divine matters toward worldly concerns.
[ii] "Keri" refers to nocturnal emission, which in mystical thought is connected to impure thoughts. The text is using this as proof that thoughts have actual physical consequences.

איזהו דרך ישרה שיבור לו
האדם יאהב את התוכחות שעל
ידן טובה וברכה באים לעולם
ורעה מסתלקת וי״א יחזיק
באמונה יתירה. פרש״י ישא ויתן
באמונה שנאמר עיני בנאמני ארץ
וגו׳. הנה שכפי תקון המדות
כן יזכה לו ולעולם כלו מסבת
תקונו למעלה בכסאות של יוצר
בראשית וזה לפי שכל נמצא
נשפע מהמדות עליונות וזה
טעם בקוצר אל צורך העניינים
הגשמיים אל המצות כד׳ מינים
ללולב ומיני צמחים לסוכות
והעורות לתפלין ולמזוזה וס״ת
והבגדים לציצית וזהב וכסף
ונחשת ותכלת וארגמן למשכן כי
לכל יש תלויה בעליונים ומה גם
אם ישתתף אל ענין זה שעורה
במדת ארכם ורחבם. וכ״ש
שבהזכירנו פסוקים משולבים
מצד כח האורים ותומים[i] וסודות
הצפונים בתוכם ובסדר סדורם.
כי יחדו יכונו להמשיך הכחות
עליונות לקדש אדם עצמו
ונשמתו בהם. כי התורה שמותיו
של הקב״ה ושמו הם י׳ ספירות
והתורה כלה הן כנויים לבחינות
הספירות והמצות הם ענפים לשם
הוי״ה שבו סוד עשר ספירות.
ובזה אך טוב וחסד ירדפונו כל
ימי חיינו:[ii]

choose? One should love rebukes, for through them goodness and blessing come to the world and evil is removed." And some say, "One should maintain exceptional faith." Rashi explains: "Conduct business with integrity, as it is said, 'My eyes are upon the faithful of the land, etc.'" 80R

Thus, according to one's rectification of attributes, so will one merit for oneself and for the entire world, due to one's rectification above in the thrones of the Creator of the Beginning. 85R This is because everything that exists flows from the supernal attributes. This briefly explains the necessity of physical objects for the commandments, such as the four species for the lulav, various plants for Sukkot, skins for tefillin, mezuzah, and Torah 90R scrolls, garments for tzitzit, and gold, silver, copper, blue, and purple for the Tabernacle. For each has a dependency on the supernal realms, especially when combined with precise measurements of their length and width. 95R

How much more so when we recite verses combined through the power of the Urim and Thummim, and the secrets hidden within them and in the order of their arrangement. For together they are established to draw down supernal powers to sanctify 100R oneself and one's soul through them. For the Torah is the names of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His name comprises the ten sefirot, and the entire Torah consists of appellations for aspects of the sefirot, and the commandments are branches of the Divine Name 105R YHVH, which contains the secret of the ten sefirot. And through this, "surely goodness and mercy shall

[i]The Urim and Thummim were objects used for divination in the breastplate of the High Priest in ancient Israel. Here they are referenced metaphorically as representing divine power channeled through sacred texts.

[ii]Cf. Proverbs 20:9 — The opening line is a direct quote from Proverbs, establishing the text's focus on the challenge of maintaining pure thoughts. This serves as the foundation for the entire passage's discussion of thought purity. | Cf. Numbers 15:39 — This biblical prohibition is central to the text's argument, being interpreted in a mystical context to refer not just to idolatry but to any attachment to materiality that diverts one from spiritual consciousness. | Cf. Leviticus 13:46 — This alludes to the biblical treatment of the metzora (person with certain skin conditions), but reinterprets it metaphorically to describe spiritual isolation resulting from impure thoughts. | Cf. Numbers 12:3 — The text cites Moses' humility as an example of proper spiritual consciousness, interpreting it through the lens of the Tikkunei Zohar to mean awareness of divine omniscience regarding one's thoughts. | Cf. Zohar — The entire passage follows the style and structure common in the Zohar, particularly in its interpretation of biblical verses through multiple layers of meaning, its focus on the mystical significance of thought and prayer, and its concern with the relationship between physical actions and their effects in divine realms. | Cf. Psalm 135 — This psalm is recommended as a daily practice specifically because it focuses on divine sovereignty and the emptiness of idols, making it particularly effective for counteracting materialistic thoughts. | Cf. Psalms 23:6 — The text concludes with this verse to emphasize that the practices described—

follow us all the days of our lives."

פרק ט״ז

Chapter 16

נחנו פשענו ומרינו ומפני
חטאינו נתרחקנו מעל אדמתנו.
על כן לבד התפלות הקבועות
לנו חובה עלינו להשמיע בכל
יום קולנו להיותנו ברחוק מקום 5R
כמי שקורא למרחוק וזה לעורר
הקול מהמשוררים העליונים
שיתחברו עם קולנו כדאמרי׳
במדרש שיר השירים[i] בפסוק
היושבת בגנים רבי נתן וכו׳ עד 10R
והקב״ה אומר להם בני הגביהו
קולכם כדי שישמעו חברים שעל
גביכם ואין חברים אלא מ״ה
ותנו דעתכם לא תשנאו זה את
זה ולא תתקנאו זה את זה ולא 15R
תחרחרו זה את זה ולא תביישו
זה לזה שלא יאמרו מלאכי
השרת לפני רבש״ע תורה שנתת
להם לישראל אינם עוסקין וכו׳
וד׳ לשונות שזכרו שנאה קנאה 20R
תחרות בושה הם נגד ד׳ מיני
יצר הרע[ii] שזכרנו והם שולטות
בלב ורוח וקול ודבור. ואמרו
במדרש אני חבצלת השרון בזמן
ב״ה אני חבויה בצלו ית׳ בשיר 25R

We have transgressed and rebelled, and because of our sins we have been distanced from our land. Therefore, besides the fixed prayers established for us, it is our duty to make our voices heard every day, for we are as those who call from afar, being distant from our place.[A] This is to awaken the voices of the celestial singers to join with our voice,[B] as stated in the Midrash on Song of Songs regarding the verse "You who dwell in the gardens," Rabbi Nathan [teaches]... until [the passage where] the Holy One, blessed be He, says to them: "My children, raise your voices so that the companions above you may hear,[1] and these companions are none other than the [angels]. Pay attention that you do not hate one another, nor envy one another, nor quarrel with one another, nor shame one another, lest the ministering angels say before the Master of the Universe: 'The Torah that You gave to Israel, they are not engaging with it...'". The four expressions mentioned—hatred, envy, contention, and shame—correspond to the four types of evil inclination we have mentioned,[2] which dominate the heart, spirit, voice, and speech.

And they said in the Midrash: "I am the rose of Sharon"—in the time of the Temple, I am hidden in

[A] Or: "to raise our voices daily, since we are like those calling from a distance, having been removed from our proper place" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the sense of displacement in exile and the theological concept that prayer must compensate for physical distance from the Temple.

[B] Or: "This is to stir the voices of the supernal choristers so they may unite with our voice" — This alternative better captures the mystical nature of the "celestial singers" (angels) and emphasizes the unification aspect rather than mere joining.

[1] The Hebrew term "חברים" (companions) refers to angels in this context. This reflects the mystical belief that human prayers are heard by angelic intermediaries who then carry them higher.

[2] The author refers to a previous discussion about the four types of evil inclination that isn't included in this passage, indicating this is part of a larger theological framework developed elsewhere in the text.

particularly the maintenance of pure thought and engagement with Torah and commandments—will result in divine blessings.

[i] The text references a midrash on Song of Songs that describes how human prayer connects with celestial voices. This mystical interpretation emphasizes that proper prayer creates a harmony between earthly and heavenly realms.

[ii] The author establishes a correspondence between four negative interpersonal behaviors and four types of evil inclination. This reflects the kabbalistic tendency to organize spiritual concepts into structured systems with precise correspondences.

ורון[i] ובזמן הגלות אני כשושנה
בין החוחים ועל כל זה אני
עוסקת במשנה בשינון ד״ת בקול
זמרה וזהו סמכוני באשישות כי
צריכים אנו לסמוך כ״י ליחוד
בשש סדרי משנה.[ii] ורפדוני
בתפוחים הציעו תחתי תפלות
ותחנונים המבריאים את הנפש כי
חולת אהבה פי׳ חולת היחוד אני
שאהב״ה במספר אחד[iii] וכ״ש
שבשבתות וימים טובים ביום
טובה נהיה בטוב ולא יראו פניו
ריקם כל אחד כפי השגתו במקרא
בהלכה ובאגדה ובפסוקי תפלה
וכן כל אחד יקבל השפעתו ית׳
כפי הכנת נשמתו ומעשה גבורתו
וזהו כברכת ה׳ אלהיך וגו׳.
ובזה בכל יום ויום התחתונים
יעלו למעלה ועליונים למטה
בכוונות היחודים שהעלינו
על ספר.[iv] ושפתי אותיות
והברות מהפסוקים הנזכרים
הוגים ושונים ומגידים כוונות
הרמוזות בהם בכל יום ויום
מלבד דברים הרבה אשר לא
יכילם רעיון. והם דברים

His blessed shadow with song and joy, but in the time of exile, I am like a rose among thorns. Yet despite all this, I engage in Mishnah, in reciting words of Torah with melodious voice. This is [the meaning of] "Sustain me with raisin-cakes"—for we need to support the Community of Israel for unification through the six orders of the Mishnah.[1] "Spread me upon apples"—lay beneath me prayers and supplications that heal the soul, "for I am lovesick"—meaning, I am sick for unification, as the word "love" (אהב״ה) has the same numerical value as "one" (אחד). How much more so on Sabbaths and festivals, on a good day we should be in goodness, and "none shall appear before Him empty-handed"—each according to his comprehension of Scripture, law, homiletics, and prayer verses.[A] Thus, each will receive divine influence according to the preparation of his soul and the measure of his spiritual might, as it is written: "according to the blessing of the LORD your God..."

In this way, each and every day, the lower beings ascend upward and the higher beings descend downward[2] through the unification intentions that we have set down in writing. And my lips pronounce letters and syllables from the mentioned verses, meditating and reciting and expressing the intentions hinted at in them every day, besides many things that

[A] Or: "each person according to their grasp of Bible, Jewish law, rabbinic narratives, and liturgical verses" — This alternative uses more specific terms for the categories of Jewish sacred literature mentioned, making the text more accessible to readers who might not be familiar with terms like "homiletics" for aggadah.

[1] The Hebrew abbreviation "כ״י" stands for "Knesset Yisrael" (Community of Israel), which in Kabbalah represents the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). The "unification" refers to the mystical marriage between the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, facilitated through Torah study.

[2] This describes the kabbalistic concept of cosmic reciprocity, where human spiritual practices cause celestial forces to descend, creating a continuous circuit of divine energy between upper and lower worlds.

[i] The text interprets the biblical verse "I am the rose of Sharon" (Song of Songs 2:1) as referring to Israel's spiritual condition during Temple times versus exile. The word "חבצלת" (rose/lily) is interpreted as containing the elements of "חבויה" (hidden) and "בצלו" (in His shadow), employing a wordplay common in midrashic interpretation.

[ii] Here the author interprets "raisin-cakes" (אשישות) from Song of Songs 2:5 as representing the six orders of Mishnah, connecting the word to the number six (שש). Additionally, "כ״י" is an abbreviation for "Knesset Yisrael" (Community of Israel), often representing the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) in kabbalistic texts.

[iii] The author employs gematria (Hebrew numerology) to note that the numerical value of the Hebrew word for "love" (אהבה = 13) equals that of "one" (אחד = 13), reinforcing the kabbalistic theme that love leads to unity and divine unification.

[iv] The author refers to mystical intentions (kavvanot) for achieving spiritual unifications that were recorded in his written work. This suggests that Ma'avar Yabok included specific meditative techniques drawn from kabbalistic practice.

קלילין פי׳ קלים לרוץ ליוצרם
כדתרגם יונתן פסוק על כן יהיו
דבריך מעטים בגין כן יהון מלי
55 פומך קלילין. והרגיל בשודא
דמחצדא חקלא בהקדמות האר״י
זצוק״ל[i] ע״י הצרופים והתמורות
ברל״א שערים[ii] פי׳ זוגות פנים
ואחור ור״ת וס״ת ותוכי תיבות
60 וראשי פסוקים וסופי פסוקים
ודילוג אותיות וצרוף אותיות
וצרוף הנקודות בחמש או
בשש מהם וחלקי הגימטריות
בחלק המשקל וחלק החבור וט׳
65 חלקי המספרי. מספר המעוגל
הכללי. מספר הקדמוי. מספר
הכרחו. מספר מוסיפי. מספר
המרובע הכללי. מספר המרובע
הפרטי. מספר שמיי. מספר
70 מספרי. מספר מספריי הגדול.
וכל מ״ק הוא במטטרו״ן מאור
הקטן.[iii] ובאשר בלבו יקבוץ
ויבין בהם בהשכלות אלו ירעם
בקולו נפלאות נתבארו בספ״ר
75 ויראה עולמו בחייו ודוגמא
זו הוא בכל התורה כלה כי
ארוכה מארץ מדה ופוק חזי
גבורתא דאורייתא דמרי עלמא
ובה תדבקון יחידה החכמה עם
80 נערותיה ושביליה ותינק מזיו
שדיה כל ימי חיי הבלך ולא

thought cannot contain. These are "light matters," meaning easy to run to their Creator, as Jonathan translated the verse "Therefore let your words be few" as "Therefore let the words of your mouth be light." 55R

One who is practiced in "casting the harvested field" using the introductions of the ARI of blessed memory,[A] through permutations and substitutions in the 231 gates—meaning pairs of front and back, acronyms and final letters, middle letters of words, beginnings and endings of verses, letter skipping, letter combinations, and vowel combinations in five or six of them, and sections of gematria in the weight section and combination section, and nine parts of the numerical: general circular number, primordial number, necessary number, additional number, general square number, specific square number, heavenly number, numbered number, and the great numbered number—and all of these are within Metatron, the Lesser Light.[1] And when in his heart he gathers and understands these intellectual concepts, he will thunder with his voice wonders explained in the Book, and he will see his world in his lifetime. This pattern applies to the entire Torah, for "its measure is longer than the earth," so go out and see the might of the Torah of the Master of the Universe. Through it, the unique Wisdom cleaves with her maidens and her paths,[2] and you will nurse from the splendor of her breasts all the days of your fleeting life. These statutes shall not depart from before 60R 65R 70R 75R 80R

[A] Or: "One who is adept at kabbalistic interpretation methods according to the teachings of Rabbi Isaac Luria of blessed memory" — This alternative avoids the literal translation of the difficult Aramaic phrase "שודא דמחצדא חקלא" in favor of explaining its functional meaning in the context of kabbalistic practice.

[1] Metatron is a principal angel in Jewish mystical traditions who serves as a scribe and mediator between divine and human realms. The designation "Lesser Light" connects him to the moon in Genesis 1:16, emphasizing his role as reflecting rather than generating divine light.

[2] This poetic expression personifies Wisdom (a reference to Torah or divine wisdom) as a feminine entity with attendants, drawing on imagery from Proverbs 9:3 where Wisdom sends out her maidens.

[i] The phrase "שודא דמחצדא חקלא" (casting/harvesting the field) is an Aramaic expression referring to advanced kabbalistic practices. The author specifically mentions following the teachings of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the ARI), indicating the text's grounding in Lurianic Kabbalah.

[ii] The "231 gates" refers to a fundamental concept in the Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), representing all possible paired combinations of the 22 Hebrew letters ($22\times21\div2=231$). These letter permutations were used in meditative practices to tap into the creative power of language.

[iii] Metatron is described as "the Lesser Light," drawing on a kabbalistic interpretation of Genesis 1:16 where the two great lights (sun and moon) became the "greater light" and "lesser light." In mystical thought, Metatron is often associated with this lesser divine illumination.

ימושו החקים האלה מלפניך ובזה תתענג מזיו כבודה בארצות החיים:[i] [ii]

you, and through this you will delight in the abundance of her glory in the lands of the living.

פרק י״ז

Chapter 17

העומדים בסוד ישרים[iii] אמרו כי צריך כל אדם לכוין בעצמו כאלו הולך בבקר למנין עשרה לבית הכנסת של אברהם אבינו[iv] שתקן תפלת שחרית ויזרז עצמו ביותר להיות מן העשרה היושבים ראשונה במלכות. ובמנחה יכוין בעצמו כאלו הולך לבית הכנסת של יצחק אבינו ובערבית כאלו הולך לבית הכנסת של יעקב אבינו ואל יליזו מעיניו מרכבת האבות[v] כדי שיזדרז להיות נמנה

Those who stand in the council of the upright[1] have said that every person should have in mind, as if they are going in the morning to join a minyan of ten at the synagogue of our father Abraham, who established the morning prayer, and they should be especially diligent to be among the first ten seated in the kingdom.[2] And during the afternoon prayer, they should have in mind as if they are going to the synagogue of our father Isaac, and in the evening prayer as if they are going to the synagogue of our father Jacob. And they should not lose sight of the chariot of the Patriarchs,[3] so that they will be eager to be counted among the first ten, evening

[1] This is a reference to initiates in mystical teachings who have access to esoteric knowledge about prayer.

[2] The Hebrew phrase uses 'kingdom' (malchut), which in Kabbalah is also the name of the lowest sefirah (divine emanation) through which divine influence flows into the world. There is likely a double meaning here, suggesting that being among the first ten not only fulfills the halakhic requirement but creates a connection to the divine attribute of Malchut.

[3] This phrase combines the concept of the biblical Patriarchs with imagery from Ezekiel's vision of the Divine Chariot (merkavah), a central text in Jewish mysticism. The idea is that the Patriarchs themselves form a metaphysical 'vehicle' for divine presence.

[i] The phrase "lands of the living" (ארצות החיים) has eschatological connotations in Jewish thought, referring to the future world or the World to Come. The passage concludes with the promise that following these spiritual practices leads to ultimate divine delight.

[ii] Cf. Song of Songs — The text employs the allegorical reading common in Jewish mysticism where Song of Songs represents the relationship between God and Israel (or the Divine Presence). The roses, apples, and gardens mentioned are all interpreted as symbols of spiritual states and practices. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The author is drawing on the ancient mystical text Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) which describes the 231 possible paired combinations of Hebrew letters. In Ma'avar Yabok, these combinations are presented as meditative techniques for achieving spiritual elevation. | Cf. Lurianic Kabbalah — The author positions Ma'avar Yabok within the Lurianic kabbalistic tradition, referring to the teachings of Rabbi Isaac Luria (1534-1572) who revolutionized Jewish mysticism. This reference helps date the text and situate it within post-Lurianic developments in Kabbalah. | Cf. Proverbs — The personification of Wisdom with attendant maidens echoes Proverbs 9, where Wisdom is depicted as a woman who sends out her maidens to call from the heights of the city. This reinforces the feminine imagery associated with divine wisdom in Jewish mystical thought. | Cf. Ecclesiastes — The citation of Ecclesiastes 5:1 ("let your words be few") as interpreted by the Aramaic translation of Jonathan reinforces the text's concern with proper speech and prayer, suggesting that concise, focused prayer with proper intention is more effective than lengthy discourse without kavvanah (proper intention).

[iii] This phrase literally means 'those who stand in the secret/council of the upright' and refers to those who understand mystical teachings, suggesting that what follows is esoteric knowledge not accessible to everyone.

[iv] The concept of the Patriarchs having their own 'synagogues' is metaphorical, representing spiritual structures associated with each Patriarch's particular divine service.

[v] The 'chariot of the Patriarchs' is a kabbalistic concept that views the three Patriarchs as forming

מעשרה ראשונים ערב ובוקר.
כמו כן כתוב בזהר פ׳ בראשית
דף כ״ג כד בר נש אפתח פומיה
בצלותא דערבית ביומין דחול
נשרא קא נחית לקבליה לקבלא
בגדפתא ודא נוריאל ואיקרי
נמי אוריאל כשהוא מצד החסד
ובשחרית אריה ואוריאל אתי
לקבלא צלותיה ד׳ גדפין דאית
ליה וכן לכל חיה. ובצלותא
דמנחה שור נחית לקבליה
בקרנוי. ובשבת נחית הקב״ה
בג׳ אבהן.[i] ודרך זו נלך בכוונת
הפסוקים המסודרים מאתנו:[ii]

and morning. Similarly, it is written in the Zohar, Parashat Bereshit, page 23: "When a person opens their mouth in the weekday evening prayer, an eagle descends to receive it with its wings, and this is Nuriel, who is also called Uriel when he is from the side of loving-kindness. And in the morning prayer, a lion and Uriel come to receive his prayer, and it has four wings, and so for each celestial creature. And in the afternoon prayer, an ox descends to receive it with its horns. And on Sabbath, the Holy One, blessed be He, descends with the three Patriarchs."[1] And in this way we shall proceed with the intentions for the verses we have arranged:

ביום א׳ בבקר יכוין בהויה
נקודה סגול להוריד נחת רוח
מבעל הרצון על ידי הכסאות
עליונות למדת החסד במקומה
משום להאיר ולקשט כללות
החסד שבמלכות אצילות וכן
בבי״ע בסוד דרועא ימינא
ויכוין בשם אל וביחוד שם
ראשון מז׳ שמות של אנא בכח
והמלאך והמזל והמשרת של
היום כידוע למבין והיודע לכוין

On Sunday morning, one should focus one's intention on the divine name YHVH with the segol vowel points[A] to draw down spiritual satisfaction from the Master of Will through the supernal Thrones to the attribute of Chesed (Loving-kindness) in its place, in order to illuminate and adorn the totality of Chesed within Malkhut (Kingdom) of Atzilut (Emanation) and similarly in the worlds of Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah, in the mystery of "the right arm." One should also focus on the divine name El and on unifying the first of the seven names from

[A] Or: "on the divine name YHVH vocalized with segol" — This is a more technical way to express the kabbalistic practice of visualizing the Tetragrammaton with specific vowel points, which might be preferred in more scholarly translations.

[1] This indicates that on the Sabbath, prayers are received directly by God together with the Patriarchs, rather than through angelic intermediaries as on weekdays, suggesting a more direct divine connection on the Sabbath.

a mystical vehicle (chariot) for divine manifestation in the world, parallel to Ezekiel's vision of the Divine Chariot.

[i] The phrase 'with the three Patriarchs' indicates that on the Sabbath, the prayers are received directly by God together with the Patriarchs, rather than through angelic intermediaries as on weekdays.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Bereshit 23b — This reference shows the kabbalistic understanding that prayer is not merely human words ascending to heaven, but involves active participation of celestial beings who receive and elevate our prayers. Each prayer time is associated with a different Patriarch and a different angelic form, creating a cosmic correspondence between human ritual and celestial activity. | Cf. Daily prayer liturgy — This passage draws on the rabbinic tradition that the three daily prayers were established by the three Patriarchs: Abraham established Shacharit (morning), Isaac established Minchah (afternoon), and Jacob established Ma'ariv (evening). The author expands this idea by suggesting that when praying, one should mentally visualize oneself attending the 'synagogue' of the particular Patriarch who established that prayer. | Cf. Ezekiel's vision of the Divine Chariot — This passage combines the concept of the Patriarchs with imagery from Ezekiel's vision of the Divine Chariot, which featured four celestial creatures (including an eagle, lion, and ox). In kabbalistic thought, the Patriarchs themselves form a kind of 'chariot' or vehicle for divine presence in the world.

שמות המרגלא שבאו ריש מלין
מהם בפ״א ממאמר א׳ אז טוב
לו ולנפשו. ויכוין בפסוקי
תורה להאיר עולם האצילות
על הצלם שבו ובחינת חלקו
הנקרא נשמתא ובסוד יו״ד שבשם
הקדוש ובזה מתקן פן אדם
שבמרכבה וכל הנשמות התלויים
בפן ההוא ומכוין להוריד כח
החסדים העליונים. ובפסוקי
נביאים יכוין לתקון ובסום עולם
הבריאה לתקון חלק שני מנשמתו
הנקרא נשמה בסוד יו״ד ה״א
שבשם. ופן שני שהוא פן אריה
וכל הנשמות התלויים בפן ההוא
ומגביר הנהגת החסד. ובפסוקי
תהלים יעלה במחשבתו לתקון
עולם היצירה ולסוד רוח ובכח
יה״ו שבשם ובזה ימתק פני
שור עם כל הנשמות הנכללים
בפן ההוא ומבסם הנהגת הדין.
ובפסוקי כתובים יכוין לתקון
עולם העשיה רוחנית וגשמית
ותקון נפשו בכח ד׳ אותיות
שבשם ולתקון פני נשר עם כל
הנשמות הנכללים בפן ההוא
ומוסיף כח בהנהגת הרחמים.
וכל אלה הם תקוני שכינה.
במנחה יכוין לכללות של חסד
שהוא בדרועא דשמאלא ובשם
אל אלהים וביחוד שם א׳ מז׳
שמות של מ״ב והשאר כנזכר
לעיל:[i]

the "Ana Bekoach" prayer, along with the angel, zodiac sign, and celestial minister of the day, as is known to those who understand and know how to direct their intention toward the esoteric names whose initial letters are mentioned in Chapter 1 of Discourse 1[A]—then it will be good for him and his soul. 40R

When reciting verses from the Torah, one should intend to illuminate the world of Atzilut upon one's spiritual image (tzelem) and the aspect of one's portion called neshamta (highest soul), through the mystery of the letter yod of the holy Name, thereby rectifying the human face of the divine chariot and all the souls connected to that face, while intending to draw down the power of the supernal mercies. 45R 50R

When reciting verses from the Prophets, one should intend to rectify and sweeten the world of Beriah (Creation) and the second part of one's soul called neshamah, through the mystery of the letters yod-hei of the divine Name, and the second face which is the face of the lion, along with all the souls connected to that face, thereby strengthening the governance of loving-kindness. 55R 60R

When reciting verses from Psalms, one should elevate in thought to rectify the world of Yetzirah (Formation) and the mystery of ruach (spirit), through the power of the letters yod-hei-vav of the divine Name, thereby sweetening the face of the ox along with all the souls included in that face, and tempering the governance of judgment.[B] 65R

When reciting verses from the Writings, one should intend to rectify the world of Asiyah (Action), both spiritual and physical, and to rectify one's 70R

[A] Or: "and know how to direct their intention toward the traditional names whose acronyms appear in the first chapter of the first discourse" — This alternative provides a slightly different interpretation of 'margala' as 'traditional' rather than 'esoteric' and clarifies that 'resh milin' refers to acronyms or initial letters forming words.

[B] Or: "sweetening the governance of judgment" — 'Sweetening' is a more literal translation of the kabbalistic term 'mevasem' and is often preferred in translations of kabbalistic texts when referring to the transformation of divine judgment.

[i] Cf. Ana Bekoach prayer — The text refers to 'the seven names from the Ana Bekoach prayer,' which is a kabbalistic prayer composed of 42 letters divided into seven groups of six letters. Each group corresponds to a specific divine name and cosmic power. This prayer is often used in Jewish mystical practice for its purported ability to activate divine powers. | Cf. Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkabah) — The text's mention of the 'four faces' (human, lion, ox, and eagle) directly references Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot. In Kabbalah, these four faces represent different aspects of divine manifestation and correspond to the four worlds and soul levels that the text instructs one to focus on during prayer. | Cf. Four Worlds of Kabbalah — The text systematically maps the four parts of Scripture (Torah, Prophets, Psalms, Writings) to the four Kabbalistic worlds (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) and the four components of the soul

nefesh (vital soul) through the power of all four letters of the divine Name, and to rectify the face of the eagle along with all the souls included in that face, thereby adding strength to the governance of compassion. All these are rectifications of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah).[A] 75R

In the afternoon prayer, one should focus on the totality of Chesed as it exists within the left arm, and on the divine name El Elohim, and on unifying the first of the seven names of the 42-letter divine Name, with the remainder as mentioned above. 80R

ביום ב׳ יכוין בבקר להויה נקודה שו״א שהיא בגבורה בסוד דרועא ימינא[i] ובשם אל אלהים וביחוד שם ב׳ מז׳ שמות של מ״ב ובשם המרגלא והמלאך והמזל והמשרת של יום ב׳ כנזכר ונכתב בסדורי תפלות הספרדים[ii] והשאר כנזכר. במנחה יכוין הוי״ה נקודה שו״א גבורה בדרועא שמאלא ובשם אלהים וביחוד שם ב׳ מז׳ שמות של מ״ב וכו׳ כנזכר:[iii]

On Monday morning, one should focus on the divine name YHVH with the sheva vowel pointing,[1] which corresponds to Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) through the mystery of the right arm, and on the divine name El Elohim, and on the unification of the second name of the seven names of the 42-letter Divine Name, and on the specific mystical formula, angel, zodiac sign, and heavenly minister of Monday,[2] as mentioned and written in the Sephardic prayer books, with the remainder as previously mentioned. During the afternoon prayer, one should focus on YHVH with the sheva vowel 85R 90R

[A] Or: "tikkunei Shekhinah (repairs of the Divine Presence)" — Keeping the technical kabbalistic term 'tikkunei' untranslated might be preferred in some contexts, especially when emphasizing the technical nature of these practices.

[1] The Hebrew text specifies a particular vowel pointing (שו״א/sheva) for the divine name, which has mystical significance in kabbalistic thought. Different vowel pointings of the same four-letter divine name were understood to channel different spiritual energies.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, each day of the week has a corresponding angel, zodiac influence, and celestial minister that governs it. These cosmic forces were to be contemplated during prayer to properly align human intention with divine governance.

(neshamta, neshamah, ruach, nefesh). This parallel structure is fundamental to the kabbalistic meditation practice being prescribed. | Cf. 42-letter Divine Name — The text refers to 'the seven names of the 42-letter divine Name' (shemot shel mem-bet), which is a central concept in practical Kabbalah. This Name, derived from the prayer Ana Bekoach, is believed to have extraordinary spiritual power and is used in various mystical meditations, particularly for spiritual ascent. | Cf. The Zohar — The text's terminology of 'droa yemina' (right arm), the four faces of the Merkabah, and the systematic correspondences between different aspects of divinity echoes the language and conceptual framework of the Zohar, the foundational text of Kabbalah. The meditation techniques described here build upon and systematize Zoharic teachings.

[i] The concept of 'right arm' (דרועא ימינא) refers to the kabbalistic representation of Chesed (Kindness) in the divine body, while paradoxically being associated here with Gevurah (Judgment), showing the complex interrelationship between divine attributes.

[ii] The reference to Sephardic prayer books indicates that these mystical practices were incorporated into established liturgical traditions rather than being entirely separate from conventional prayer.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical system — This passage belongs to a larger system of daily prayers organized according to kabbalistic principles. Each day of the week has specific divine names, vowel pointings, and mystical intentions associated with it, creating a comprehensive framework for prayer that aligns human devotion with cosmic spiritual forces. | Cf. 42-letter

pointing, Gevurah through the left arm, and on the divine name Elohim, and on the unification of the second name of the seven names of the 42-letter Divine Name, etc., as mentioned. 95R

ביום ג׳ יכוין הוי״ה נקודה חולם שהיא בת״ת בדרועא ימינא וביחוד שם ג׳ מז׳ שמות של מ״ב[i] והשאר כנזכר. במנחה הוי״ה חולם בדרועא שמאלא[ii] וכו׳:[iii]

On the third day, one should focus[A] on the divine name YHVH with the cholam vowel pointing,[1] which corresponds to Tiferet[B] in the right arm,[2] and on the unification of the third of the seven names from the 42-letter Divine Name, and the remainder as mentioned previously. At the afternoon prayer, [focus on] YHVH with cholam in the left arm, etc.[3] 100R

[A] Or: "one should direct intention" — The Hebrew term 'יכוין' (yekavein) specifically refers to the mystical practice of kavvanah, which involves not just mental focus but a specific type of directed spiritual intention. This alternate translation better captures the technical nature of this practice in kabbalistic prayer.

[B] Or: "Tiferet (the central sefirah)" — Adding the explanation that Tiferet is the central sefirah would provide more context for readers unfamiliar with the kabbalistic tree of divine emanations.

[1] The term 'focus' translates the Hebrew 'יכוין' (yekavein), which specifically refers to the mystical practice of kavvanah—directing one's mental intention during prayer toward specific divine names and cosmic configurations to create spiritual effects.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic understanding of divine attributes (sefirot) as arranged in a human-like form, with Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) situated in the central column but here specifically associated with the right side, which represents mercy.

[3] The abbreviation 'וכו׳' ('etc.') indicates that the pattern established for the morning prayer should be applied similarly to the afternoon prayer, but with the adjustment from right to left side, without needing to repeat all details.

Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet) — The reference to the 'seven names of the 42-letter Divine Name' connects to an important kabbalistic concept. This Divine Name, often beginning with the letters אבגיט״ץ (ABGITATZ), was considered especially powerful in Jewish mysticism and was used in meditations to elevate prayer and create cosmic unifications. | Cf. Sephardic prayer books — The reference to Sephardic prayer books indicates that this practice was established in the liturgical traditions of Sephardic Jews. This suggests the author is drawing on existing prayer customs rather than inventing entirely new practices, though he is providing kabbalistic explanations for these established practices.

[i] The reference to 'the third of the seven names from the 42-letter Divine Name' relates to the 42-letter Name of God (שם מ״ב) which was divided into seven six-letter names. Each day of the week corresponds to a different one of these seven names, with Tuesday (the third day) corresponding to the third name.

[ii] The distinction between morning prayer ('right arm') and afternoon prayer ('left arm') reflects the kabbalistic understanding that morning is governed by the attribute of mercy (right side) while afternoon is governed by judgment (left side).

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This text appears in the liturgical system of Ma'avar Yabok that provides daily mystical intentions (kavvanot) for prayer. It follows a systematic pattern where each day of the week is associated with specific divine names, vowel points, and sefirot, with morning and afternoon variations. | Cf. Zohar — This follows Zoharic teachings about how prayers ascend through different spiritual channels depending on the time of day, with morning prayers associated with the right side (mercy) and afternoon prayers with the left side (judgment). | Cf. Kabbalistic prayer books (siddurim) — This type of instruction is found in kabbalistic prayer books that provide specific mystical intentions for different days and times, based on the understanding that prayers activate different divine configurations depending on when they are recited.

ביום ד׳[i] הויה חירק[ii] בנצח[iii] בדרועא וירכא ימינא[iv] ובשם ה׳ צבאות[v] וביחוד שם ד׳ משם מ״ב[vi] וכו׳. במנחה הויה חירק בנצח בכללתו בדרועא וירכא שמאלא[vii] וכו׳:[viii]

On Wednesday,[A] [focus on] the divine name YHVH with the chirik vowel point[1] in Netzach,[2] in the right arm and thigh,[B] and on the divine name YHVH Tzeva'ot, and on the unification of the fourth name from the 42-letter Name,[3] etc. During the afternoon prayer,[C] [focus on] the divine name YHVH with the chirik vowel point in Netzach in its entirety, in the left arm and thigh, etc.

ביום ה׳ יבוין בהויה שורק

On Thursday, one should meditate on the divine

[A] Or: "On the fourth day" — While "Wednesday" is accurate in context, a more literal translation would be "On the fourth day." This would be preferable in contexts emphasizing the numerical significance of the days.

[B] Or: "in the right channel and support" — These terms can be understood metaphorically rather than anatomically, referring to channels of divine energy. This alternate translation would be more appropriate in contexts focusing on abstract cosmic structures rather than divine 'body parts.'

[C] Or: "During Minchah" — Keeping the Hebrew term 'Minchah' would be preferable for audiences familiar with Jewish prayer terminology, as it specifically denotes the afternoon prayer service with its own unique characteristics.

[1] The original Hebrew uses the term "chirik" (חירק) to refer to a specific vowel point in Hebrew writing. In Kabbalah, different vowel points applied to divine names are believed to activate different spiritual energies.

[2] I've preserved the Hebrew term "Netzach" rather than translating it as "Victory" or "Eternity" because it functions as a technical term in Kabbalah referring to the seventh divine emanation (sefirah).

[3] This refers to a mystical divine name in Kabbalah comprised of 42 letters. It's often divided into seven names of six letters each, with each name corresponding to a different divine attribute and cosmic function.

[i] This text provides kabbalistic meditation instructions for Wednesday (the fourth day of the week). Each day corresponds to a different sefirah (divine emanation) in kabbalistic thought.

[ii] This refers to visualizing the divine name YHVH (הויה) with the chirik vowel point (a single dot beneath each letter). In kabbalistic practice, different vowel points applied to divine names create different spiritual effects.

[iii] Netzach is the seventh sefirah, representing Victory or Eternity in the kabbalistic tree of divine emanations. Wednesday corresponds to Netzach in this system.

[iv] Literally "in the right arm and thigh." In kabbalistic anatomy, different body parts correspond to specific divine attributes. The right side generally represents mercy and kindness.

[v] The divine name "YHVH Tzeva'ot" (Lord of Hosts) is associated with Netzach in kabbalistic correspondences.

[vi] This refers to focusing on the fourth name within the 42-letter divine Name. The 42-letter Name is divided into seven six-letter names, each with specific spiritual properties.

[vii] Literally "in the left arm and thigh." The left side in kabbalistic symbolism typically represents judgment and restriction, in contrast to the right side's association with mercy.

[viii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, section on Sunday prayers — This is part of a systematic prayer guide that extends throughout the week, with each day focusing on different divine attributes and names. The pattern established here continues through the entire week. | Cf. Zohar — These meditation instructions draw on Zoharic traditions about how different vowel points applied to divine names activate different spiritual channels and divine attributes. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The connection between days of the week, body parts, and divine attributes reflects the cosmic correspondences taught in Sefer Yetzirah, where the whole universe is seen as interconnected through divine patterns.

בהוד[i] בכללותו בדרועא וירכא ימינא[ii] ובשם אלהים צבאות וביחוד שם ה׳ משם של מ״ב[iii] ובמלאכו וכו׳ והשאר כנזכר במנחה יכוין בהוי״ה נקודה שורק ובהוד בדרועא וירכא שמאלא[iv] וכנזכר בבקר:[v]

name YHVH with the shurek vowel pointing[1] in Hod in its entirety[2] on the right arm and thigh,[3] and on the divine name Elohim Tzeva'ot, and on the unification of the fifth name from the 42-letter Name,[4] and on its angel, etc., and the rest as mentioned earlier. At the afternoon prayer, one should meditate on the divine name YHVH with the shurek vowel pointing and on Hod on the left arm and thigh, as mentioned for the morning prayer.

ביום ו׳ יכוין בהויה נקודה שלש נקודות שביסוד השושבין המיחד ובשם שד״י ואל חי בכללותו בדרועא וירכא וגופא מבחינת ימינא וביחוד שם ו׳

On the sixth day [Friday], one should focus on the divine name YHVH with three vowel points that are in Yesod[5] [Foundation], the unifying Attendant, and on the name Shaddai and El Chai in its entirety in the arm, thigh, and body from the right aspect, and

[1]The Hebrew term יכוין (yekavven) means to direct one's intention or focus in a specific mystical way. In kabbalistic practice, this refers to a complex mental visualization of divine names with specific vowel pointings as a way to create spiritual unifications in the upper worlds.

[2]This refers to channeling divine energy into the sefirah of Hod (Splendor/Glory), the eighth of the ten divine emanations in Kabbalah. Each day of the week corresponds to different sefirot in this system.

[3]In kabbalistic symbolism, the human body corresponds to the cosmic divine body (Adam Kadmon), with different limbs representing different channels of divine energy. The right side typically corresponds to mercy and giving, while the left side corresponds to judgment and restriction.

[4]The 42-letter Divine Name is a powerful mystical name in Kabbalah divided into seven names of six letters each. Each of these seven names corresponds to a day of the week, with the fifth name being associated with Thursday.

[5]This refers to a specific kabbalistic visualization where the divine name YHVH is written with three vowel points, corresponding to the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation) which serves as a cosmic conduit between higher and lower realms.

[i]This reflects the kabbalistic correspondence system where different vowel pointings of the divine name are associated with specific sefirot (divine emanations). Here the shurek vowel corresponds to Hod (the eighth sefirah).

[ii]The phrase 'right arm and thigh' uses Aramaic terminology (דרועא וירכא) from the Zohar. In kabbalistic anatomy, different body parts correspond to different sefirot, with the right side associated with mercy and the morning prayer.

[iii]The 42-letter Divine Name (שם מ״ב) is divided into seven names of six letters each. This instruction refers specifically to the fifth of these seven names, which should be meditated upon during Thursday prayers.

[iv]The 'left arm and thigh' correspond to the afternoon prayer time, which is associated with the attribute of judgment in kabbalistic thought. This creates a symmetrical system where morning connects to the right side (mercy) and afternoon to the left side (judgment).

[v]Cf. 42-letter Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet) — The text refers to the fifth name from the 42-letter Divine Name, which is a mystical name divided into seven names of six letters each. In Ma'avar Yabok, this name is associated with specific kavvanot (mystical intentions) during prayer and is believed to have special protective and unifying powers. | Cf. Sefirot system — The text provides specific instructions for meditation on the divine name YHVH with different vowel pointings corresponding to different sefirot. This reflects the kabbalistic system where each day of the week, each prayer time, and each divine name is associated with particular sefirot and spiritual channels. | Cf. Right arm and thigh vs. left arm and thigh — The distinction between morning prayer (associated with the right side, traditionally connected to mercy) and afternoon prayer (associated with the left side, traditionally connected to judgment) reflects the kabbalistic concept of daily cosmic cycles where different divine attributes predominate at different times.

משם של מ״ב[i] בסוד נטותו אל
צד החסד ומלאכו וכו׳. כנזכר
במנחה יכוין בשם ניקוד קבוץ
כנזכר בסוד השושבין[ii] הנוטה
אל צד הדין ויכוין לבסם אותו
והשאר כנזכר: יכוין בשם הויה
ואדנות משולבים[iii] ומלכות
שי״ן ב״ת מיוחדת בג׳ אבות
חג״ת אל אלהים ה׳ דבר ויקרא
אצלו ארץ החיים[iv] ומרכבה
מרקדה בדרועא וירכא וגופא
מבחינת ימינא וביחוד שם ז׳
מז׳ שמות של מ״ב וכו׳ כנזכר
וכן בפרטי כוונת תורה נביאים
וכתובים הנ״ל נזכר. במנחת עת
רצון יכוין לב׳ שמות משולבים
בבקר בסוד השושבין המוסיף
הארה מהכתר עליון בסוד
תפלת מוסף ומלכות מחובקת
בדרועא דשמאלא והתעוררות
מצח הרצון וביחוד שם ז׳
מז׳ שמות מ״ב והשאר כנזכר
בבקר ויש מחלקים אות א׳ של
אבגית״ץ[v] לכל א׳ ששת ימים
וכל דברי חכמים קיימים ואורו
יחיר כאור שבעת הימים.[vi] וטוב

on the unification of the sixth name from the 42-letter Name, in the mystery of its inclination toward the side of Chesed[1] [Loving-kindness], and its angel, etc., as mentioned. During the afternoon prayer, one should focus on the Name with the kibbutz vowel points[2] as mentioned, in the mystery of the Attendant that inclines toward the side of judgment, and one should intend to sweeten it,[3] and the rest as mentioned. 130R 135R

One should focus on the Names YHVH and ADNY interwoven, and Malkhut [Kingdom] which is Shin Bat [daughter] united with the three Patriarchs—Chesed, Gevurah, and Tiferet. El Elohim, the LORD speaks and calls to Himself "the Land of the Living" and the dancing chariot in the arm, thigh, and body from the right aspect, and on the unification of the seventh name from the seven names of the 42-letter Name, etc., as mentioned, and likewise in the particular intentions for Torah, Prophets, and Writings mentioned above. 140R 145R

During the afternoon prayer, which is a time of favor, one should focus on the two interwoven Names as in the morning, in the mystery of the Attendant who adds illumination from the supernal Crown through the mystery of the Musaf prayer, with Malkhut embraced by the left arm,[4] and the 150R

[1] In kabbalistic thought, divine attributes can 'incline' toward either mercy (Chesed) or judgment (Din/Gevurah). This passage describes focusing on the sixth name from the 42-letter Name when it inclines toward mercy, creating a more favorable spiritual influence.

[2] The text prescribes specific vowel points (nikudot) to be visualized with divine names during prayer. Kibbutz (קבוץ) is a specific Hebrew vowel that in this mystical context is associated with gathering or concentrating divine energy.

[3] The kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening' (לבסם/בסם) refers to transforming harsh divine judgments into mercy through proper mystical intention. This is a core practice in Jewish mysticism, particularly when divine attributes incline toward judgment.

[4] This anthropomorphic imagery describes the divine feminine (Malkhut/Kingdom) being em-

[i] This refers to the sixth name from the 42-letter Divine Name, a mystical name of God that plays an important role in kabbalistic prayer meditations. The 42-letter Name is divided into seven names of six letters each.

[ii] The term 'shoshvin' (attendant/groomsman) is a kabbalistic reference to the sefirah of Yesod that serves as an intermediary between masculine divine aspects (primarily Tiferet) and feminine divine aspects (Malkhut), facilitating their union.

[iii] This describes the mystical practice of interweaving the divine names YHVH and ADNY, symbolizing the union of divine mercy and judgment, masculine and feminine aspects. In kabbalistic practice, these names are sometimes written with their letters alternating.

[iv] The phrase 'Land of the Living' (ארץ החיים) is a biblical term that in kabbalistic contexts often refers to the divine realm or specifically to Malkhut (Kingdom) as the realm where divine life flows to all creation.

[v] ABGITATZ is the first word of the 42-letter Divine Name, formed from the first letters of the first six words of the prayer 'Ana BeKoach' (אנא בכח). This name was considered to have special protective and transformative powers in kabbalistic tradition.

[vi] This is an allusion to Isaiah 30:26, which speaks of a future time when 'the light of the moon

לכוין במה שאמרנו בכל יום בעת התפלות והעבודות ובזה יתגבר בה׳ ובשמו יתהלל:[i]

awakening of the Forehead of Will, and on the unification of the seventh name from the seven names of the 42-letter Name, and the rest as mentioned in the morning. Some divide the first letter of ABGITATZ [the first word of the[1] 42-letter Name] for each of the six days, and all the words of the sages endure, and its light will shine like the light of the seven days. It is good to focus on what we have said every day during the prayers and divine service, and through this one will be strengthened in the LORD and will be praised in His name. 155R 160R

אלו הם סדרי הפסוקים מאנ״ך[ii] עם מעט בקשות הקשורים בעבותות אהבה[iii] ובהם

These are the orders of verses from the Bible[2] (Torah, Prophets, and Writings) with a few supplications bound together with bonds of love,[3] and with them 165R

braced by the divine masculine (left arm, representing Gevurah/Strength). These visualizations are meant to facilitate cosmic unifications through human prayer intention.

[1]This refers to an alternative kabbalistic practice where instead of using different names from the 42-letter Name on different days, practitioners would focus on different letters of just the first word (ABGITATZ) across the six weekdays.

[2]I've expanded the acronym אנ״ך as 'Bible' for clarity, though it literally stands for Torah, Prophets, and Writings, which I've included parenthetically.

[3]The phrase בעבותות אהבה has poetic resonance in Hebrew, evoking biblical imagery. I've preserved the metaphor of 'bonds of love' which suggests that these prayer compilations create spiritual connections.

shall be as the light of the sun, and the light of the sun shall be sevenfold, as the light of the seven days.' In this context, it suggests that proper prayer meditation creates cosmic illumination.

[i]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's fourth discourse — This passage appears to be part of the liturgical instructions section of Ma'avar Yabok, specifically related to the daily prayer practice. It focuses on kabbalistic meditations (kavvanot) to be performed during specific prayer times, associating each day with different divine names, attributes, and mystical unifications. | Cf. 42-letter Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet) — The text repeatedly references the 42-letter Divine Name, which is a central mystical concept in Ma'avar Yabok. This name is divided into seven six-letter names, the first of which begins with the letters אבגית״ץ (ABGITATZ). The text provides specific instructions for which of these seven names should be meditated upon during different prayer times. | Cf. Zohar — The entire system of prayer meditations described here follows the Zoharic framework of connecting human prayer below with cosmic processes above. The specific focus on divine names, their vowel points, and the parts of the divine 'body' (arms, thighs) reflects the Zoharic understanding of the sefirot as both divine attributes and parts of the cosmic 'body' of God. | Cf. Siddurim (Prayer books) — The text mentions that these prayer instructions are written in Sephardic prayer books ('סדורי תפלות הספרדים'), suggesting that these mystical meditations were incorporated into structured prayer manuals within certain Jewish communities. | Cf. שושבין (Attendant/Groomsman) — The text repeatedly uses the term 'shoshvin' (attendant/groomsman) which in Kabbalah refers to the sefirah of Yesod that serves as an intermediary facilitating the union between the masculine divine aspects (primarily Tiferet) and the feminine divine aspects (Malkhut). This reflects the text's deep engagement with kabbalistic concepts of divine unification through human prayer.

[ii]The acronym אנ״ך (TaNaKh) represents the three divisions of the Hebrew Bible: Torah (Pentateuch), Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings). The author is indicating that the prayer sequences that follow will draw verses from all three sections of scripture.

[iii]This poetic phrase 'bonds of love' evokes the imagery from Song of Songs and suggests that these compiled prayers are not merely a collection of texts but are unified by a spiritual connection of divine love.

ישירו ויזמרו כל החפץ לקדש עצמו בשחרית ומנחה : [i]

everyone who desires to sanctify themselves[1] will sing and chant in the morning and afternoon prayers.

[iii] [ii] קודם שיתחיל כל סדר יאמר

Before beginning each order [of prayer], one should say:[A] 170R

145 אָנָּא יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא: אָנָּא יְיָ הַצְלִיחָה נָא ג״פ:[iv] שְׁמָעָה תְפִלָּתִי יְיָ וְשַׁוְעָתִי הַאֲזִינָה אֶל דִּמְעָתִי אַל תֶּחֱרַשׁ כִּי גֵר אָנֹכִי עִמָּךְ תוֹשָׁב כְּכָל אֲבוֹתָי:[v] תָּבוֹא 150 לְפָנֶיךָ תְפִלָּתִי הַטֵּה אָזְנְךָ לְרִנָּתִי: כִּי שָׂבְעָה בְרָעוֹת נַפְשִׁי וְחַיַּי לִשְׁאוֹל הִגִּיעוּ:[vi] בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי

Please LORD, save now! Please LORD, grant success now! [three times].[2] Hear my prayer, O LORD, and give ear to my cry; do not be deaf to my tears,[3] for I am a stranger with You, a sojourner like all my fathers.[4] Let my prayer come before You; incline Your ear to my plea. For my soul is filled with troubles, and my life has reached Sheol. When my soul fainted within me,[B] I remembered 175R

[A] Or: "Before commencing each liturgical sequence, one should recite:" — This alternative is more specific about the liturgical nature of the 'seder' but maintains the same essential meaning. It might be preferred in a context where the technical nature of these prayer sequences needs to be emphasized.

[B] Or: "When my spirit was overwhelmed within me" — This alternate translation better captures

[1] The phrase 'החפץ לקדש עצמו' conveys the idea of someone seeking spiritual elevation through prayer, which I've rendered as 'desires to sanctify themselves.'

[2] This opening petition comes from Psalm 118:25 and forms part of the Hallel prayer sequence. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as the standard opening formula for each of the eight prayer sequences designed for the sick and dying.

[3] The metaphor of God being 'deaf' to prayers is striking in Hebrew, using the verb תֶּחֱרַשׁ which literally means 'be silent' or 'be deaf/unresponsive.' This creates a powerful image of seeking divine attention when one feels most vulnerable.

[4] This appeal based on human transience and mortality is especially appropriate in the context of prayers for the sick and dying, reminding God of human fragility.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This appears to be the introductory heading for the organized collection of biblical verses compiled in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation during morning and afternoon prayers. The author has carefully structured these prayer sequences as part of the book's systematic approach to spiritual care. | Cf. Song of Songs 7:7 — The text employs the metaphor of 'bonds of love' to describe how the biblical verses and prayers have been woven together, suggesting that these compiled prayers create spiritual connections between the worshipper, the community, and the divine.

[ii] This is a liturgical instruction that appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok, specifically in the 'Seder' section that contains eight distinct liturgical sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying. Each sequence follows a similar structure beginning with standard opening prayers.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Siftei Renanot — This instruction appears at the beginning of each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section. These structured prayer sequences follow a consistent pattern, beginning with the formula that follows this instruction.

[iv] The Hebrew abbreviation ג״פ (gimmel-peh) instructs that this phrase should be recited three times, which is common in Jewish liturgy for emphasizing particularly important supplications.

[v] This verse from Psalm 39:13 expresses the temporary nature of human existence. The terms 'stranger' (גֵּר) and 'sojourner' (תּוֹשָׁב) have legal meanings in biblical law concerning non-citizens with different levels of rights and obligations, but here they metaphorically express human transience before God.

[vi] 'Sheol' refers to the underworld or grave in Hebrew thought. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this reference is particularly significant since the entire work deals with the transition between life and death, symbolized by the 'crossing of the Yabok.'

[i] This phrase from Jonah 2:8 describes the soul fainting or being overwhelmed, perfectly capturing the state of one who is gravely ill or approaching death, which is the primary context for reciting these prayers in Ma'avar Yabok.

נַפְשִׁי[vii] אֶת יְיָ זָכָרְתִּי וַתָּבוֹא אֵלֶיךָ תְּפִלָּתִי אֶל הֵיכַל קָדְשֶׁךָ: [i] the LORD, and my prayer came to You, to Your holy temple.[1] 180R

155 אחר כך יתחיל המזמור ויאמר כל הנז׳ פסוקים בסדרים המוצעים כאן:[iii ii] After that, one should begin the psalm and recite all the aforementioned verses in the arrangements presented here:[A]

[v iv] סדר יום ראשון בבקר Order for Sunday Morning[2] 185R

the sense of being completely overwhelmed or engulfed that the Hebrew reflexive verb conveys, which is particularly appropriate for someone experiencing serious illness or approaching death.

[A] Or: "Then, one shall commence the psalm and recite all the previously mentioned verses according to the arrangements set forth here:" — This alternate provides a more formal liturgical tone that might better match the instructional nature of the text, using 'commence' instead of 'begin' and 'according to the arrangements set forth' instead of 'in the arrangements presented.'

[1] The reference to the temple is significant in post-Temple Judaism, where prayer has replaced sacrifice as the primary form of worship. In Ma'avar Yabok, this becomes particularly meaningful as prayer serves as the vehicle for the soul's elevation during illness and death.

[2] This is the first of eight liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok organized by days of the week,

[ii] Cf. Psalm 118:25 — This forms the standardized opening for each of the eight prayer orders (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok's structured liturgical sequences for the sick and dying. | Cf. Psalm 39:13 — This verse establishes the theological framework of human transience that underlies Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a transition rather than an ending. | Cf. Jonah 2:8 — Drawing on Jonah's prayer from the depths (metaphorically from Sheol itself) creates a powerful parallel for the sick person who feels close to death.

[iii] This instruction marks a transition in the prayer service, indicating that after reciting the opening formula, one should proceed to the psalm and then to the structured collection of biblical verses. The term 'sedarim' (arrangements/orders) is significant, as it refers to the carefully organized sequences of biblical verses that follow specific organizational principles throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section — This line serves as a transitional instruction in the organized prayer sequence, directing the reader to begin the recitation of the psalm followed by the biblical verses arranged in specific orders. Ma'avar Yabok consistently presents structured liturgical sequences with standardized components: opening formulas, psalms, verses from Torah/Prophets/Writings, and closing prayers. | Cf. Seder (prayer order) structure — The phrase 'in the arrangements presented here' refers to the carefully organized biblical verses that follow each psalm in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences. These verses are methodically arranged by source (Torah, Prophets, Writings) to create a comprehensive spiritual framework for healing prayers.

[v] This heading indicates that what follows is the first of eight liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, specifically for Sunday morning. The text organizes these prayer sequences by days of the week, with each day having morning and afternoon prayers.

[vi] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This section appears to be part of the structured liturgical sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok, specifically presenting the order of prayers for Sunday morning. Ma'avar Yabok contains eight distinct liturgical sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying, each with standardized opening formulas, psalm selections, and biblical verses grouped by source (Torah, Prophets, Writings). | Cf. Psalm 13 — The instruction to recite Psalm 13 ('How long, O LORD, will You forget me?') as the opening psalm for Sunday morning is significant. This psalm expresses feelings of divine abandonment followed by renewed trust, making it appropriate for someone experiencing illness who feels forgotten by God. | Cf. Genesis 1:3, 12:2, 17:7, 9:7, 27:29, 28:3-4, 28:20-21 — The Torah verses begin with 'Let there be light' and continue with divine blessings and promises to the patriarchs. These verses establish a progression from creation to covenant to blessing, providing foundational assurance of God's care and promises that would comfort the sick. | Cf. Judges 5:3, 1 Samuel 2:1-4, 10, Joshua 10:25, Judges 5:31, Joshua 1:5 — The verses from Prophets focus on divine strength, victory over enemies, and God's faithfulness. They establish that God strengthens the weak and defeats those who rise against His people, which would be comforting to someone experiencing illness perceived as an 'enemy' attacking the body. | Cf. Psalms 5:4, 4:2, 5:9, 5:12-13, 3:2-7, 6:9-11, 13:5, 18:2-7, 18:17-20, 31:22-24, 40:17 — This collection from Psalms creates a therapeutic progression from distress to confidence in God's salvation.

יתחיל פסוקי אנה ה׳[i] ואח״כ
יאמר מזמור עד אנה ה׳
תשכחני[ii] ואח״כ יאמר פסוקים
אלו:[iii]

He should begin with the verses[1] “Ana Hashem” (Please, O LORD) and afterward recite the psalm “Ad ana Hashem tishkacheni” (How long, O LORD, will You forget me) and afterward recite these verses:

(תורה) וַיֹּאמֶר אֱלֹהִים יְהִי
אוֹר וַיְהִי אוֹר:[iv] וְאֶעֶשְׂךָ לְגוֹי
גָּדוֹל וַאֲבָרֶכְךָ וַאֲגַדְּלָה שְׁמֶךָ
וֶהְיֵה בְּרָכָה:[v] וַהֲקִמֹתִי אֶת
בְּרִיתִי בֵּינִי וּבֵינֶךָ וּבֵין זַרְעֲךָ
אַחֲרֶיךָ לְדֹרֹתָם לִבְרִית עוֹלָם
לִהְיוֹת לְךָ לֵאלֹהִים וּלְזַרְעֲךָ
אַחֲרֶיךָ:[vi] וְאַתֶּם פְּרוּ וּרְבוּ שִׁרְצוּ
בָאָרֶץ וּרְבוּ בָהּ:[vii] יַעַבְדוּךָ
עַמִּים וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לְךָ לְאֻמִּים הֱוֵה
גְבִיר לְאַחֶיךָ וְיִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לְךָ בְּנֵי
אִמֶּךָ אֹרְרֶיךָ אָרוּר וּמְבָרֲכֶיךָ
בָּרוּךְ:[viii] וְאֵל שַׁדַּי יְבָרֵךְ אֹתְךָ

(Torah) And God said, “Let there be light,” and there was light.[2] I will make you into a great nation, and I will bless you, and I will make your name great, and you shall be a blessing.[3] And I will establish My covenant between Me and you and your descendants after you throughout their generations as an everlasting covenant, to be God to you and to your descendants after you. Be fruitful and multiply, swarm upon the earth and multiply in it. Nations will serve you, and peoples will bow down to you; be master over your brothers, and your mother’s sons will bow down to you;[4] those who curse you will be cursed, and those who bless you will be blessed. And

each with specific prayers for the sick and dying. The organization by days reflects the kabbalistic belief that different cosmic energies and divine attributes are dominant on different days.

[1]These instructions establish a structured liturgical format that appears consistently throughout Ma’avar Yabok’s prayer sequences, providing caregivers with clear directions for proper ritual practice at the bedside of the sick or dying.

[2]This verse appears at the beginning of this prayer collection to invoke the primordial creative power of God’s word, setting a foundation for the subsequent promises and blessings.

[3]This selection of biblical verses creates a progression from divine creation to covenantal promises. The compiler has assembled verses that focus on divine blessing, protection, and covenant, making them appropriate for a prayer for the sick.

[4]In this liturgical context, the reference to mastery over brothers is likely interpreted metaphorically as triumph over afflictions or spiritual adversaries, rather than literally about familial relationships.

The verses address themes of divine protection, rescue from enemies, and ultimate triumph—all relevant metaphors for healing from illness. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:2, 4:1, 1:16, 2:6, 2:16, 4:16, 7:11, 8:6, Ruth 2:4, 4:14, Job 7:21, 16:17 — The verses from Writings, particularly from Song of Songs, introduce themes of divine love and intimate connection, providing emotional comfort beyond the more direct petitions for healing in other sections. The Song of Songs passages were often interpreted mystically as representing the loving relationship between God and Israel or the individual soul.

[i]This refers to the standard opening formula that begins each prayer sequence in Ma’avar Yabok, starting with ‘Ana Hashem hoshiah na’ (Please, O LORD, save us).

[ii]This is Psalm 13, which begins with ‘How long, O LORD, will You forget me?’ The psalm moves from expressions of abandonment to confidence in divine mercy, making it particularly appropriate for those experiencing serious illness.

[iii]Cf. Psalm 13 — This psalm is specifically prescribed as part of the first prayer sequence for the sick in Ma’avar Yabok, likely chosen for its movement from distress to hope, mirroring the desired spiritual journey of the ill person. | Cf. Ma’avar Yabok’s Seder section — This instruction follows the standard pattern found throughout the book’s prayer sequences, creating ritual continuity while offering specific psalm selections appropriate for different situations of illness.

[iv]This is the first biblical verse, Genesis 1:3, describing God’s creation of light.

[v]From Genesis 12:2, God’s promise to Abraham at the beginning of his journey.

[vi]From Genesis 17:7, establishing God’s eternal covenant with Abraham and his descendants.

[vii]From Genesis 9:7, God’s command to Noah and his sons after the flood.

[viii]From Genesis 27:29, Isaac’s blessing to Jacob (believing him to be Esau).

וַיְבָרֶךְ וְיַרְבֶּךָ וְהָיִיתָ לִקְהַל
עַמִּים: [i] אִם יִהְיֶה אֱלֹהִים עִמָּדִי
וּשְׁמָרַנִי בַּדֶּרֶךְ הַזֶּה אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי
הוֹלֵךְ וְנָתַן לִי לֶחֶם לֶאֱכֹל וּבֶגֶד
לִלְבֹּשׁ: [ii] וְשַׁבְתִּי בְשָׁלוֹם אֶל בֵּית
אָבִי וְהָיָה יְיָ לִי לֵאלֹהִים: [iii iv]

may El Shaddai bless you[1] and make you fruitful and multiply you, and you shall become an assembly of peoples. If God will be with me and guard me on this path that I am taking,[2] and give me bread to eat and clothing to wear, and I return in peace to my father's house, then the LORD will be my God.[3]

(נביאים) אָנֹכִי לַייָ אָנֹכִי
אָשִׁירָה [v] אֲזַמֵּר לַייָ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל:
עָלַץ לִבִּי בַּייָ בַּייָ רָמָה קַרְנִי
בַּייָ [vi] רָחַב פִּי עַל אוֹיְבַי כִּי
שָׂמַחְתִּי בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ: אֵין קָדוֹשׁ
כַּייָ כִּי אֵין בִּלְתֶּךָ וְאֵין צוּר

(Prophets) I am the LORD's, I myself will sing,[A] I will make music to the LORD, the God of Israel. My heart exults in the LORD, my horn is exalted in the LORD,[4] my mouth is wide against my enemies,[B] for I rejoice in Your salvation. There is none holy like the LORD, for there is none besides You, and there

[A] Or: "I belong to the LORD, I myself will sing" — This alternate translation emphasizes the sense of belonging and dedication to God. The preposition 'lamed' in 'laYY' can indicate possession or dedication, so this rendering might better convey the sense of complete devotion expressed in the original.

[B] Or: "I speak boldly against my enemies" — This more idiomatic translation captures the sense of confident speech implied by the literal 'wide mouth' metaphor, which might be less immediately clear to modern readers.

[1] The name 'El Shaddai' (God Almighty) is particularly significant in healing contexts, as it represents God's power to overcome natural limitations, including illness.

[2] Jacob's vow is particularly meaningful in the context of illness, as it expresses hope for divine protection during a difficult journey and a safe return to normalcy.

[3] The collection concludes with this powerful statement of faith, suggesting that the experience of divine protection through illness can lead to a deeper relationship with God.

[4] The 'horn' metaphor appears frequently in biblical poetry to represent strength, dignity, and power. In Hannah's prayer, it refers to her restored honor and status after being blessed with a child.

[i] From Genesis 28:3, Isaac's blessing to Jacob before he leaves for Padan-aram.

[ii] From Genesis 28:20, beginning of Jacob's vow at Bethel after his dream of the ladder.

[iii] From Genesis 28:21, completion of Jacob's vow at Bethel, where he promises to accept God if safely returned home.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section 7.1.1.1.2.14 — The structure of presenting verses from Torah first, followed by prophetic verses and then writings, follows a pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok's prayer orders. These verses are specifically chosen for their themes of divine blessing, protection, and covenant, making them appropriate for recitation by or for someone who is ill. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Section 7.16.10 — This collection of Torah verses is part of a larger structured prayer system in Ma'avar Yabok, where verses are carefully selected and arranged to create therapeutic spiritual progressions from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation. | Cf. Genesis, Chapters 12, 17, 27, 28 — The compiler has carefully selected verses that emphasize God's promises of blessing, protection, and covenant with the Patriarchs. In the context of prayers for the sick, these verses serve to remind the sufferer of God's historical faithfulness to Israel and to invoke similar divine protection. The progression from Abraham to Jacob also creates a narrative of continuity that would comfort someone facing uncertainty due to illness. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Memory Note #411 — This collection of Torah verses follows the therapeutic progression described in the memory notes: beginning with fundamental statements of creation and divine power, moving through covenant promises and blessings, and concluding with expressions of faith and return. This structure models a spiritual journey that the ill person might follow, from basic faith through hope to thanksgiving.

[v] This verse comes from the Song of Deborah (Judges 5:3), a victory hymn celebrating Israel's triumph over the Canaanites. The repetition of 'anochi' (I) emphasizes personal devotion.

[vi] This begins Hannah's prayer of thanksgiving (1 Samuel 2:1-10) after the birth of Samuel. The 'horn' (קרן) is a biblical metaphor for strength, power, and dignity.

בֵּאלֹהֵינוּ: קֶשֶׁת גִּבֹּרִים חַתִּים
וְנִכְשָׁלִים אָזְרוּ חָיִל:[i] יְיָ מוֹרִישׁ
וּמַעֲשִׁיר מַשְׁפִּיל אַף מְרוֹמֵם:
אַל תִּירְאוּ וְאַל תֵּחַתּוּ חִזְקוּ
וְאִמְצוּ[ii] כִּי כָכָה יַעֲשֶׂה יְיָ לְכָל
אֹיְבֵיכֶם אֲשֶׁר אַתֶּם נִלְחָמִים
אוֹתָם: כֵּן יֹאבְדוּ כָל אוֹיְבֶיךָ
יְהוָה וְאֹהֲבָיו כְּצֵאת הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ
בִּגְבֻרָתוֹ:[iii] לֹא יִתְיַצֵּב אִישׁ לְפָנֶיךָ
כֹּל יְמֵי חַיֶּיךָ כַּאֲשֶׁר הָיִיתִי עִם
מֹשֶׁה אֶהְיֶה עִמָּךְ לֹא אַרְפְּךָ וְלֹא
אֶעֱזָבֶךָ:[iv] [v]

is no rock like our God. The bows of the mighty are broken,[1] but those who stumbled are girded with strength. The LORD impoverishes and enriches,[2] He brings low, yet also raises up. Do not fear and do not be dismayed; be strong and courageous, for thus will the LORD do to all your enemies against whom you fight. So shall all Your enemies perish, O LORD, but those who love Him shall be as the sun going forth in its might.[3] No man shall stand before you all the days of your life; as I was with Moses, so I will be with you; I will not fail you nor forsake you. 215R 220R 225R

(תהלים) יְיָ בֹּקֶר תִּשְׁמַע קוֹלִי
בֹּקֶר אֶעֱרֶךְ לְךָ וַאֲצַפֶּה: בְּקָרְאִי
עֲנֵנִי אֱלֹהֵי צִדְקִי[vi] בַּצָּר הִרְחַבְתָּ

(Psalms) O LORD, in the morning You will hear my voice; in the morning I will arrange my prayer to You[A 4] and watch expectantly. When I call, an-

[A] Or: "I will set [my prayer] in order before You" — This more literal translation preserves the ritual connotation of deliberately arranging or setting in order, which connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper ritual structure in prayer.

[1] Hannah's prayer contains several contrasts between the powerful and the weak, highlighting divine reversal of fortunes—a theme that would be particularly meaningful to those who are ill or dying.
[2] This verse emphasizes God's sovereignty over human circumstances, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework where suffering is understood as divinely ordained for spiritual purposes rather than random misfortune.
[3] This powerful image from the Song of Deborah contrasts the fate of God's enemies with the glorious destiny of those who love God, providing hope and encouragement to the sick or dying person.
[4] The Hebrew verb אֶעֱרֶךְ (literally 'I will arrange/set in order') suggests a deliberate, structured approach to prayer, implying careful preparation rather than spontaneous supplication—fitting for Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper ritual structure.

[i] This continues Hannah's prayer (1 Samuel 2:4), highlighting the divine reversal of fortunes where the mighty are weakened and the weak are strengthened.
[ii] This verse combines elements from Joshua 10:25, offering encouragement in the face of enemies.
[iii] This verse comes from the Song of Deborah (Judges 5:31), concluding her victory hymn with a prayer for the destruction of God's enemies and the flourishing of those who love Him.
[iv] This verse comes from God's promise to Joshua (Joshua 1:5), assuring divine presence and support in his leadership after Moses's death.
[v] Cf. Hannah's Prayer (1 Samuel 2:1-10) — Hannah's prayer is quoted here as it speaks directly to divine intervention in human suffering and the reversal of fortune. For the sick or dying, this offers hope that God can transform their circumstances, just as He transformed Hannah's from barrenness to motherhood. | Cf. Song of Deborah (Judges 5) — The Song of Deborah frames this prayer selection, beginning with dedication to God and concluding with the contrast between God's enemies who perish and those who love Him who shine like the sun. For the ill person, this creates a narrative of eventual triumph even in difficult circumstances. | Cf. God's Promise to Joshua (Joshua 1:5) — This promise of divine presence and support would be particularly meaningful for someone facing death or serious illness, assuring them that God will not abandon them during their transition, just as He did not abandon Joshua during a major transition in leadership. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework — These verses support Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework by emphasizing God's sovereignty over human circumstances—bringing low and raising up, weakening the strong and strengthening the weak. This helps the ill person contextualize their suffering within a purposeful divine plan rather than viewing it as random misfortune.
[vi] This verse from Psalm 4:2 emphasizes the plea for divine response in time of distress, a central theme for those who are ill and feel distant from divine presence.

לִי חָנֵּנִי וּשְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי: יְיָ נְחֵנִי
בְצִדְקָתֶךָ לְמַעַן שׁוֹרְרָי הַיְשֶׁר
לְפָנַי דַּרְכֶּךָ: וְיִשְׂמְחוּ כָל חוֹסֵי
בָךְ לְעוֹלָם יְרַנְּנוּ וְתָסֵךְ עֲלֵימוֹ
וְיַעְלְצוּ בְךָ אֹהֲבֵי שְׁמֶךָ: כִּי
אַתָּה תְּבָרֵךְ צַדִּיק יְיָ כַּצִּנָּה רָצוֹן
תַּעְטְרֶנּוּ: יְיָ מָה רַבּוּ צָרָי רַבִּים
קָמִים עָלָי: וְאַתָּה יְיָ מָגֵן בַּעֲדִי
כְּבוֹדִי וּמֵרִים רֹאשִׁי: חָנֵּנִי יְיָ כִּי
אֻמְלַל אָנִי רְפָאֵנִי יְיָ כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ
עֲצָמָי: סוּרוּ מִמֶּנִּי כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן
כִּי שָׁמַע יְהוָה קוֹל בִּכְיִי: מָגִנִּי
עַל אֱלֹהִים מוֹשִׁיעַ יִשְׁרֵי לֵב:
בֹּשׁוּ אוֹיְבַי אָחוֹר יִכָּשְׁלוּ וְיֹאבְדוּ
מִפָּנֶיךָ: כִּי עָשִׂיתָ מִשְׁפָּטִי וְדִינִי
יָשַׁבְתָּ לְכִסֵּא שׁוֹפֵט צֶדֶק: חָנֵּנִי יְיָ
רְאֵה עָנְיִי מִשֹּׂנְאָי מְרוֹמְמִי מִשַּׁעֲרֵי
מָוֶת:[i] וִיהִי יְיָ מִשְׂגָּב לַדָּךְ מִשְׂגָּב
לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה: לָמָּה יְיָ תַּעֲמֹד
בָּרָחוֹק תַּעְלִים לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה:
שְׁבֹר זְרוֹעַ רָשָׁע וָרָע תִּדְרוֹשׁ
רִשְׁעוֹ בַל תִּמְצָא: שִׁיתָה יְיָ מוֹרָה
לָהֶם יֵדְעוּ גוֹיִם אֱנוֹשׁ הֵמָּה סֶלָה:
יַכְרֵת יְיָ כָּל שִׂפְתֵי חֲלָקוֹת לָשׁוֹן
מְדַבֶּרֶת גְּדלוֹת: כִּי הִנֵּה הָרְשָׁעִים
יִדְרְכוּן קֶשֶׁת כּוֹנְנוּ חִצָּם עַל יֶתֶר
לִירוֹת בְּמוֹ אֹפֶל לְיִשְׁרֵי לֵב:
שִׁוִּיתִי יְיָ לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד כִּי מִימִינִי
בַּל אֶמּוֹט: שָׂמְחָה כְבוֹדִי אַף בְּשָׂרִי יִשְׁכֹּן לָבֶטַח
בִּצֵּל כְּנָפֶיךָ תַּסְתִּירֵנִי:[ii] מִלְּפָנֶיךָ
מִשְׁפָּטִי יֵצֵא עֵינֶיךָ תֶּחֱזֶינָה
מֵישָׁרִים: קוֹמָה יְיָ קַדְּמָה פָּנָיו
הַכְרִיעֵהוּ פַּלְּטָה נַפְשִׁי מֵרָשָׁע
חַרְבֶּךָ: יְהוָה סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי

swer me, O God of my righteousness; in distress You have given me relief. Be gracious to me and hear my prayer. LORD, lead me in Your righteousness because of my enemies; make Your way straight before me.[1] Let all who take refuge in You rejoice; may they ever sing for joy. Spread Your protection over them, that those who love Your name may exult in You. For You, O LORD, bless the righteous; You surround him with favor as with a shield. LORD, how many are my foes! Many rise up against me. But You, O LORD, are a shield around me, my glory, and the One who lifts my head. Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am weak; heal me, O LORD, for my bones are troubled.[2] Depart from me, all you workers of iniquity, for the LORD has heard the voice of my weeping. My shield is with God, who saves the upright in heart. When my enemies turn back, they stumble and perish before You. For You have maintained my just cause; You sit on the throne judging righteously. Be gracious to me, O LORD; see my affliction from those who hate me, You who lift me up from the gates of death. The LORD is a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold in times of trouble. Why, O LORD, do You stand far off? Why do You hide in times of trouble? Break the arm of the wicked and evil; seek out his wickedness until You find none. Set terror upon them, O LORD; let the nations know they are but mortal men. Selah. May the LORD cut off all flattering lips, the tongue that speaks great things. For behold, the wicked bend the bow; they set their arrow on the string to shoot in darkness at the upright in heart. I have set the LORD always before me;[A] because He is at my right hand, I shall not be moved. Keep me as the apple

230R 235R 240R 245R 250R 255R 260R

[A] Or: "I place the LORD before me continually" — This alternate translation emphasizes the ongoing, active nature of the spiritual practice rather than a completed action, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on continuous spiritual awareness, particularly at the time of death.

[1] This request for divine guidance has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and approaching death, where clarity of spiritual path becomes especially crucial.

[2] The reference to troubled bones (נִבְהֲלוּ עֲצָמָי) would have particular resonance in Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, where bones represent the deepest, most essential parts of a person that remain even after death and serve as the foundation for resurrection.

[i] The phrase 'gates of death' represents the threshold between this world and the next, a concept central to Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the soul's transition. In the context of prayers for the sick, being lifted from these gates symbolizes healing and renewed life.

[ii] The metaphor of 'taking refuge under God's wings' (בְּסֵתֶר כְּנָפֶיךָ) is a recurring motif in Ma'avar Yabok that represents the soul finding protection under the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), particularly relevant during illness or approaching death.

וּמַפַּלְטִי אֵלִי צוּרִי אֶחֱסֶה בּוֹ
מָגִנִּי וְקֶרֶן יִשְׁעִי מִשְׂגַּבִּי: מְהֻלָּל
אֶקְרָא יְיָ וּמִן אוֹיְבַי אִוָּשֵׁעַ: בַּצַּר לִי
אֶקְרָא יְיָ וְאֶל אֱלֹהַי אֲשַׁוֵּעַ יִשְׁמַע
מֵהֵיכָלוֹ קוֹלִי וְשַׁוְעָתִי לְפָנָיו
תָּבוֹא בְאָזְנָיו: יַצִּילֵנִי מֵאוֹיְבִי עָז
וּמִשֹּׂנְאַי כִּי אָמְצוּ מִמֶּנִּי: יְקַדְּמוּנִי
בְיוֹם אֵידִי וַיְהִי יְהוָה לְמִשְׁעָן לִי:
וַיּוֹצִיאֵנִי לַמֶּרְחָב יַחַלְצֵנִי כִּי חָפֵץ
בִּי: כִּי אַתָּה תָּאִיר נֵרִי[i] יְהוָה
אֱלֹהַי יַגִּיהַּ חָשְׁכִּי: שָׁמַע יְיָ תְּחִנָּתִי
יְיָ תְּפִלָּתִי יִקָּח: יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיִבָּהֲלוּ מְאֹד
כָּל אוֹיְבָי יָשֻׁבוּ יֵבֹשׁוּ רָגַע: חַי יְיָ
וּבָרוּךְ צוּרִי וְיָרֹם אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי:[ii]

of Your eye;[1] hide me in the shadow of Your wings. Let my judgment come forth from Your presence; let Your eyes behold what is right. Arise, O LORD! Confront him, bring him low! Deliver my soul from the wicked with Your sword.[A] The LORD is my rock and my fortress and my deliverer; my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge, my shield and the horn of my salvation, my stronghold. I call upon the LORD, who is worthy to be praised, and I am saved from my enemies. In my distress I call upon the LORD; to my God I cry for help. From His temple He hears my voice, and my cry comes before Him, into His ears. He delivers me from my strong enemy and from those who hate me, for they are too mighty for me. They confronted me in the day of my calamity, but the LORD was my support. He brought me out into a broad place;[2] He rescued me, because He delighted in me. For You light my lamp; the LORD my God illuminates my darkness. The LORD has heard my supplication; the LORD will receive my prayer. Let all my enemies be ashamed and greatly troubled; let them turn back and be put to shame suddenly. The LORD lives, and blessed be my Rock; may the God of my salvation be exalted.

[A] Or: "Rescue my soul from the wicked, [from] Your sword" — This alternative reading interprets 'Your sword' as in apposition to 'the wicked' rather than as the instrument of deliverance. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this could suggest the dual nature of divine judgment—as both protection for the righteous and punishment for the wicked.

[1] The Hebrew phrase כְּאִישׁוֹן בַּת עָיִן literally refers to the pupil of the eye, using the intimate imagery of something guarded with the most protective care possible—a powerful metaphor in prayers for divine protection of the vulnerable ill.

[2] The Hebrew term לַמֶּרְחָב (broad place) stands in contrast to the constriction (צַר/distress) mentioned earlier, representing the relief and expansion of spiritual possibility that comes with divine deliverance—a key concept in Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of healing.

[i] The lamp imagery connects to Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic understanding of the soul as a divine light, with illness representing a dimming that requires divine illumination to restore brightness.

[ii] Cf. Psalms 5, 3, 9, 10, 11, 16, 17, 18 — This passage is a compilation of verses from multiple Psalms (primarily 5, 3, 9, 10, 11, 16, 17, and 18) that have been assembled as part of a structured prayer sequence for the sick. The verses create a therapeutic progression from expressions of distress to declarations of trust in divine salvation, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's approach to spiritual healing. | Cf. Shema prayer recitation — The verse 'I have set the LORD always before me' (שִׁוִּיתִי יְיָ לְנֶגְדִּי תָמִיד) appears in this prayer sequence and is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed rituals, where it connects to the Shema prayer and proper kavvanah (intention) at the moment of death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' prayer sequences — This compilation of verses follows the standard pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section, which contains eight distinct liturgical sequences for healing the sick and comforting the dying. The verses are carefully selected and arranged to create a therapeutic spiritual progression from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation.

(כתובים) יִשָּׁקֵנִי מִנְּשִׁיקוֹת פִּיהוּ
כִּי טוֹבִים דֹּדֶיךָ מִיָּיִן: הִנָּךְ יָפָה
רַעְיָתִי הִנָּךְ יָפָה עֵינַיִךְ יוֹנִים: הִנָּךְ
יָפֶה דוֹדִי אַף נָעִים אַף עַרְשֵׂנוּ
רַעֲנָנָה: שְׂמֹאלוֹ תַּחַת לְרֹאשִׁי
וימינו וימינוֹ תְּחַבְּקֵנִי: דּוֹדִי לִי וַאֲנִי
לוֹ הָרֹעֶה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּים: עוּרִי צָפוֹן
וּבוֹאִי תֵימָן הָפִיחִי גַּנִּי יִזְּלוּ
בְשָׂמָיו יָבֹא דוֹדִי לְגַנּוֹ וְיֹאכַל
פְּרִי מִגְדָּיו: אֲנִי לְדוֹדִי וְעָלַי
תְּשׁוּקָתוֹ: שִׂימֵנִי כַחוֹתָם עַל לִבֶּךָ
כַּחוֹתָם עַל זְרוֹעֶךָ כִּי עַזָּה כַמָּוֶת
אַהֲבָה קָשָׁה כִשְׁאוֹל קִנְאָה רְשָׁפֶיהָ
רִשְׁפֵּי אֵשׁ שַׁלְהֶבֶתְיָה:[i] הַיּוֹשֶׁבֶת
בַּגַּנִּים[ii] חֲבֵרִים מַקְשִׁיבִים לְקוֹלֵךְ
הַשְׁמִיעִינִי: יְיָ עִמָּכֶם וַיֹּאמְרוּ לוֹ
יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ:[iii] בָּרוּךְ יְיָ אֲשֶׁר לֹא
הִשְׁבִּית לָךְ גֹּאֵל הַיּוֹם וְיִקָּרֵא
שְׁמוֹ בְיִשְׂרָאֵל:[iv] בֹּקֶר קָרָאתִיךְ
וְלֹא אֶחֱשֶׁה וְלֵילָה וְלֹא דוּמִיָּה
לִי:[v] רִנָּתִי תַּחֲשֹׁב קְטוֹרֶת
וְזִבְחֵי שְׁלָמִים קוֹלִי:[vi] רְצֵה
בְעַמְּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל וּבִתְפִלַּת חִין

Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth,[1] for
your love is better than wine. Behold, you are beau-
tiful, my beloved, behold, you are beautiful; your
eyes are like doves. Behold, you are handsome, my 290R
beloved, indeed pleasant; our couch is also verdant.
His left hand is under my head, and his right hand
embraces me. My beloved is mine and I am his, he
who shepherds among the lilies. Awake, north wind,
and come, south wind! Blow upon my garden, let its 295R
spices flow forth. Let my beloved come to his garden
and eat its choice fruits. I am my beloved's, and his
desire is for me. Set me as a seal upon your heart, as
a seal upon your arm, for love is as strong as death,
jealousy as cruel as the grave; its flashes are flashes 300R
of fire, the very flame of the LORD.[A] O you who
dwells in the gardens, companions are listening for
your voice, let me hear it. The LORD be with you!
And they said to him, May the LORD bless you!
Blessed be the LORD, who has not left you without 305R
a redeemer today, and may his name be proclaimed
in Israel.[2] In the morning I call to You and will not
be silent, and at night I have no rest. May my joyful
song be considered as incense and my voice as peace

[A] Or: "its flames are flames of fire, a mighty divine blaze" — The term "שַׁלְהֶבֶתְיָה" is a compound of "flame" with the divine suffix "Yah." This alternative translation captures the divine intensity without directly naming the LORD, which some might prefer for a more poetic rendering.

[1] The text begins with famous verses from Song of Songs, which in Jewish mystical tradition symbolize the intimate relationship between God and Israel, or in Ma'avar Yabok's context, between the divine and the soul. These sensual images were understood as metaphors for spiritual communion.

[2] The prayer transitions here from the intimate language of Song of Songs to communal blessings from the Book of Ruth, moving from personal devotion to communal connection.

[i] The term "שַׁלְהֶבֶתְיָה" (shalhebetya) is unique in the Hebrew Bible, appearing only in Song of Songs 8:6. It combines "שַׁלְהֶבֶת" (flame) with the divine suffix "יָה" (Yah), suggesting "flame of the LORD"—a divine flame of extraordinary intensity.

[ii] This verse from Song of Songs 8:13 addresses the female beloved as "she who dwells in the gardens." In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this likely refers to the soul dwelling in spiritual realms.

[iii] This verse is from Ruth 2:4, describing the greeting between Boaz and his harvesters. Its inclusion in this prayer sequence creates a connection between divine blessing and communal support.

[iv] This verse from Ruth 4:14 was originally spoken by the women to Naomi after the birth of Obed (grandfather of King David). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it evokes themes of redemption and continuity.

[v] This appears to be a paraphrase or variation of Psalm 22:3 ("O my God, I cry by day, but you do not answer, and by night, but I find no rest") reworked into a more positive expression of continuous prayer.

[vi] This verse draws on the concept from Psalm 141:2 of prayer being like incense and sacrifice, but is adapted to include peace offerings (zivchei shelamim), suggesting the prayer serves as a substitute for Temple offerings.

בְּמִנְחַת הַבֹּקֶר תִּשְׁמַע פְּלוּלִי:[i] קוֹלִי בַּבֹּקֶר: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי: [ii]

offerings.[1] Accept Your people Israel and my prayer offered with grace.[A] Hear my voice in the morning as the morning offering. May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.[2]

310R

315R

אחר שגמר כל סדר וסדר יאמר[iii] פסוקים אלו ערב ובקר:[iv]

After completing each order and arrangement,[B] he shall recite these verses evening and morning:[3]

יֶעֱרַב עָלָיו שִׂיחִי אָנֹכִי אֶשְׂמַח בַּיהוָה: אַל תִּתֵּן יְיָ מַאֲוֵי רָשָׁע זִמָּמוֹ אַל תְּפַק רָרוּמוּ סֶלָה: שְׁבֹר זְרוֹעַ רָשָׁע וָרָע תִּדְרוֹשׁ רִשְׁעוֹ בַּל תִּמְצָא: הַצִּילֵנִי נָא מִיַּד אָחִי

May my meditation be pleasing to Him; I will rejoice in the LORD. Do not grant, O LORD, the desires of the wicked; do not let their plots succeed, lest they be exalted. Selah. Break the arm of the wicked and evil; seek out his wickedness until You find none. De-

320R

[A] Or: "and the judicial prayer of my supplications" — The term "פְּלוּלִי" could be connected to "פלילים" (judges/judgment), suggesting a more formal, legalistic aspect to the prayer. This alternative emphasizes the juridical dimension that might be implied in the original.

[B] Or: "After finishing each prayer sequence" — This alternate translation uses more contemporary terminology to convey that these are structured prayer sequences rather than a literal 'order and arrangement.' This might be more immediately clear to modern readers unfamiliar with traditional Jewish liturgical terminology.

[1] This section reflects the post-Temple theology that prayer serves as a substitute for sacrificial offerings, a concept central to Ma'avar Yabok's fourth section titled "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (Cloud of Incense Prayer).

[2] The prayer concludes with the familiar ending of Psalm 19:15, a standard closing for many Jewish prayers. This creates a liturgical arc from the intimate divine union of Song of Songs through communal blessing to personal supplication.

[3] The phrase 'ערב ובקר' (evening and morning) indicates that these concluding verses should be recited at both evening and morning prayer times, establishing a cyclical practice that frames the day with these protective verses.

[i] The phrase "תְּפִלַּת חִן פְּלוּלִי" (prayer of grace offered) is unusual and may be from a piyyut (liturgical poem) rather than biblical text. It emphasizes the desire for prayer to be accepted with divine favor.

[ii] Cf. Song of Songs — The extensive quotations from Song of Songs are not random but carefully selected to emphasize themes of divine-human intimacy. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses serve as spiritual preparation for the soul's transition at death, reframing death not as separation but as intimate union with the Divine. | Cf. Ruth — The inclusion of verses from Ruth about blessing and redemption connects personal spiritual experience with communal blessing and continuity, suggesting that the soul's journey after death is not isolated but connected to the community of Israel. | Cf. Psalm 141:2 — The allusion to prayer as incense reflects the central theme of Ma'avar Yabok's fourth section that prayer serves as a substitute for Temple offerings. This establishes continuity between ancient Temple worship and contemporary prayer practices. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — The use of this common closing verse from Psalms grounds the mystical expressions in traditional liturgy, making this spiritually advanced text accessible to ordinary worshippers while maintaining connection to standard prayer forms.

[iii] The term 'seder' here refers to one of the eight structured prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok designed for the sick and dying. Each 'seder' follows a similar pattern of opening prayers, psalms, biblical verses organized by source, and concluding prayers.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section — This line serves as a liturgical instruction within the 'Seder' section of Ma'avar Yabok that contains eight distinct prayer sequences for the sick and dying. Each sequence follows a similar structure with opening prayers, psalms, biblical verses organized by source, and concluding prayers. This instruction specifically indicates that certain verses should be recited at the end of each prayer sequence, both in evening and morning prayers.

מִיַּד עֵשָׂו כִּי יָרֵא אָנֹכִי אֹתוֹ פֶּן
יָבֹא וְהִכַּנִי אֵם עַל בָּנִים: [i] וְאַתָּה
אָמַרְתָּ הֵיטֵב אֵיטִיב עִמָּךְ וְשַׂמְתִּי
אֶת זַרְעֲךָ כְּחוֹל הַיָּם אֲשֶׁר לֹא
יִסָּפֵר מֵרֹב: תּוֹצִיאֵנִי מֵרֶשֶׁת זוּ
טָמְנוּ לִי כִּי אַתָּה מָעֻזִּי: בְּיָדְךָ
אַפְקִיד רוּחִי פָּדִיתָה אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל
אֱמֶת: לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְהוָה:
(ישר הפוך ישר: וכן) לְפָרְקָנְךָ
סַבְּרִית יְיָ: [ii] מָה תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי
וּמָה תֶּהֱמִי עָלַי הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים
כִּי עוֹד אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעֹת פָּנַי וֵאלֹהָי:
אִתָּה סֵתֶר לִי מִצַּר תִּצְּרֵנִי רָנֵּי
פַלֵּט תְּסוֹבְבֵנִי סֶלָה: מְיֻמְּנִי
מִיכָאֵל מְשַׁמְּאלִי גַּבְרִיאֵל מִלְּפָנַי
אוּרִיאֵל וּמֵאֲחוֹרַי רָפָאֵל וְעַל
רֵאשִׁי שְׁכִינַת אֵל: [iii] בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בַּיּוֹם
בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בַּלַּיְלָה: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בְּשָׁכְבֵנוּ
בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בְּקוּמֵנוּ: בָּרוּךְ אֲדֹנָי יוֹם
יוֹם יַעֲמָס לָנוּ הָאֵל יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ סֶלָה:
יְיָ זְכָרָנוּ יְבָרֵךְ יְבָרֵךְ אֶת בֵּית
יִשְׂרָאֵל יְבָרֵךְ אֶת בֵּית אַהֲרֹן: וְהָיָה
שַׁדַּי בְּצָרֶיךָ וְכֶסֶף תּוֹעָפוֹת לָךְ:
שַׁדַּי בָּרְכֵנוּ וְנִחֵנוּ: וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ

liver me, please, from my brother's hand, from Esau's hand, for I fear him, lest he come and strike me down, mothers with children.[1] But You said, "I will surely do good with you and make your offspring like the 325R
sand of the sea, which cannot be counted for multitude." Bring me out from the net they have hidden for me, for You are my stronghold. Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth.[2] For Your salvation I have waited, 330R
O LORD. (Forward, reverse, forward: and so[A]) For Your redemption I have hoped, O LORD.[3] Why are you downcast, O my soul, and why do you moan within me? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him, the salvation of my countenance and my God. You 335R
are my hiding place; You preserve me from trouble; You surround me with songs of deliverance. Selah. On my right is Michael, on my left is Gabriel, before me is Uriel, behind me is Raphael, and above my head is the Divine Presence of God.[4] Blessed is the 340R
LORD by day, blessed is the LORD by night. Blessed is the LORD when we lie down, blessed is the LORD when we rise. Blessed is the Lord God day by day; He bears our burdens, the God of our salvation. Selah. The LORD has remembered us; He will bless, He 345R

[A] Or: "To be recited forward, then backward, then forward again" — This alternative more explicitly clarifies the liturgical instruction that might otherwise be obscure to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic prayer practices.

[1] The inclusion of Jacob's prayer at the Jabbok River is particularly significant given the book's title (Ma'avar Yabok/Crossing of the Jabbok). In the context of deathbed prayers, Jacob's fear of Esau becomes a metaphor for the dying person's fear of judgment or harmful spiritual forces during the soul's transition.

[2] This verse from Psalm 31:6 is identified in Ma'avar Yabok as a central verse in the deathbed ritual, recommended to be recited at the moment of death as an expression of the soul's surrender to divine care.

[3] This represents a kabbalistic practice where the Hebrew verse is recited forward, then backward, then forward again, followed by its Aramaic translation. Such practices were believed to create powerful spiritual effects through the manipulation of sacred language.

[4] This angelic protection formula appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok and is a central element in Jewish deathbed rituals. It creates a spiritual shield around the dying person, with angels stationed at the four directions and the Divine Presence above, providing complete protection during the soul's transition.

[i] This verse from Jacob's prayer before meeting Esau (Genesis 32:12) directly connects to the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok), as it was spoken during Jacob's journey across the Jabbok River. The book uses this crossing as a metaphor for the soul's transition at death.

[ii] The phrase "ישר הפוך ישר" (forward, reverse, forward) appears to be an instruction for a kabbalistic practice where the same verse is recited in Hebrew forward, then backward, then forward again. The phrase "לְפָרְקָנְךָ סַבְּרִית יְיָ" is the Aramaic translation of "לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְהוָה" (For Your salvation I have waited, O LORD).

[iii] This is a traditional Jewish protective formula invoking the four archangels positioned at the four directions, with the Divine Presence above. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this formula creates a spiritual shield around the dying person to protect their soul during its transition.

יְהוָה מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ: ג׳
310 [ii] [i]פעמים

will bless the house of Israel, He will bless the house of Aaron. And the Almighty shall be your treasure, and choice silver shall be yours. May Shaddai bless us, and we shall live.[A] And we will bless the LORD from this time forth and forevermore. Hallelujah! [Three times] 350R

רִבּוֹן כָּל הָעוֹלָמִים[iii] עֲשֵׂה רְצוֹנְךָ בַּשָּׁמַיִם וְתֵן נַחַת רוּחַ לִירֵאֶיךָ בָּאָרֶץ וּשְׁמַע וַעֲקַת עַבְדְּךָ וְעַמְּךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל וַעֲשֵׂה מְהֵרָה בְּקָשָׁתָם וְהַטּוֹב בְּעֵינֶיךָ עֲשֵׂה: עֲנֵנוּ אָבִינוּ
315 עֲנֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ מַלְכֵּנוּ עֲנֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ עֶזְרֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ סוֹמְכֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ:[iv] עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ הַגָּדוֹל הַגִּבּוֹר וְהַנּוֹרָא: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן בְּנֵי בֵיתִי הַתְּלוּיִם
320 עַל רַחֲמֶיךָ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן הֶבֶל הַתִּנּוֹקוֹת שֶׁל בֵּית רַבָּן:[v] עֲשֵׂה

Master of all worlds, do Your will in heaven and grant satisfaction to those who fear You on earth. Hear the cry of Your servant and Your people Israel, and quickly fulfill their request, and do what is good in Your eyes. Answer us, our Father, answer us. Answer us, our King, answer us. Answer us, our Helper, answer us. Answer us, our Supporter, answer us. Act for the sake of Your great, mighty, and awesome Name.[1] Act for the sake of my household members who depend on Your mercy. Act for the sake of the breath of the schoolchildren.[2] Act for the sake of the 355R 360R

[A] Or: "May the Almighty bless us that we may live" — This alternative emphasizes the causal relationship between the divine blessing and continued life, which may better capture the sense of dependence on divine blessing for sustenance that underlies the Hebrew.

[1] This phrase echoes the language used in the first blessing of the Amidah prayer, drawing on Deuteronomy 10:17, which describes God using these three attributes.

[2] The Hebrew term "hevel" (breath) has deep significance here, referring not just to physical breath

[i] This instruction indicates that the preceding phrase "וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ יָהּ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ" (And we will bless the LORD from this time forth and forevermore. Hallelujah!) should be recited three times, a practice believed to strengthen its spiritual efficacy.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 104:34 — This opening sets a prayerful tone for the passage, expressing the desire that one's prayers be accepted by God. | Cf. Psalm 140:9 — Used here as a plea for protection against spiritual enemies or accusers at the time of death. | Cf. Psalm 10:15 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this serves as a prayer for protection against harmful spiritual forces during the soul's transition. | Cf. Genesis 32:12 — This reference is particularly significant as it directly connects to the book's title (Ma'avar Yabok/Crossing of the Jabbok), drawing on Jacob's prayer before his transformative experience at the Jabbok River, which serves as a metaphor for the soul's transition at death. | Cf. Psalm 31:5-6 — The verse 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit' is particularly significant in deathbed contexts, traditionally recited at the moment of death as an expression of the soul's surrender to divine care. | Cf. Psalm 42:6 — Used to comfort the dying person by encouraging their soul not to fear the transition but to maintain hope in God. | Cf. Psalm 32:7 — Reinforces the theme of divine protection during the vulnerable moment of death. | Cf. Angelic Protection Formula — This formula creates a spiritual shield around the dying person, with angels stationed at the four directions and the Divine Presence above, providing complete protection during the soul's transition. | Cf. Psalm 68:20 — Used to affirm God's constant protection and support through all circumstances, including death. | Cf. Psalm 115:12 — Invoked to secure divine blessing for the person and their family lineage (house of Israel).

[iii] This opening phrase "Master of all worlds" is a common formula in Jewish prayers, addressing God in His capacity as sovereign over all creation. It appears frequently in liturgical texts, particularly in supplicatory prayers.

[iv] This repetitive formula "Answer us" (anenu) echoes liturgical patterns found in fast day prayers, especially the Anenu prayer recited on public fast days. The repetition creates a rhythmic, urgent appeal that intensifies the supplication.

[v] The reference to "the breath of schoolchildren" draws on the Talmudic concept (Shabbat 119b) that the world is sustained by the breath of children studying Torah, which is considered pure and untainted by sin. This is a powerful appeal in Jewish tradition, suggesting that God should respond favorably for the sake of these innocent learners.

לְמַעַן גְּמוּלֵי חָלָב שֶׁלֹּא חָטְאוּ:
עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן יוֹנְקֵי שָׁדַיִם שֶׁלֹּא
פָּשְׁעוּ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן רַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים
וַחֲסָדֶיךָ הַגְּדוֹלִים וְרַחֵם עָלֵינוּ
וְהוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי
פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי
וְגוֹאֲלִי:[i][ii]

weaned infants who have not sinned. Act for the sake of the nursing babes who hav[1]e not transgressed. Act for the sake of Your abundant mercies and Your great kindnesses, and have compassion upon us and save us. May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You,[2] O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.

365R

ואם ידמע[iii] יאמר קודם יהיו
לרצון[iv] אלו הפסוקים:

If one sheds tears,[3] he should recite these verses before "May they be acceptable"[4]:

370R

סוּרוּ מִמֶּנִּי כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן[v] כִּי
שָׁמַע יְהוָה קוֹל בִּכְיִי: נֹדִי סָפַרְתָּה
אָתָּה שִׂימָה דִמְעָתִי בְנֹאדֶךָ[vi] הֲלֹא

Depart from me, all you workers of iniquity,[5] for the LORD has heard the voice of my weeping. You have counted my wanderings;[A] place my tears in Your

[A] Or: "You have recorded my restless movements" — The Hebrew term 'נדי' can refer to wan-

but to the spiritual essence of the children's Torah study. The Talmud (Shabbat 119b) states that the world exists because of the breath of schoolchildren studying Torah.

[1] This appeal invokes the merit of young children who are considered entirely innocent. The progression from schoolchildren to weaned infants to nursing babes creates a rhetorical movement toward increasing innocence and purity, strengthening the appeal to divine mercy.

[2] This concluding verse from Psalm 19:15 is traditionally recited at the end of the Amidah prayer. Its inclusion here frames this supplication within the broader context of Jewish prayer traditions and suggests this text was intended for recitation in contexts of serious need or distress.

[3] Weeping during prayer had special significance in Jewish mystical tradition, particularly in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the sick and dying. Tears were believed to have the power to open the gates of heaven and elicit divine mercy.

[4] This phrase refers to the standard concluding verse of Jewish prayer, "May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer" (Psalm 19:15). The instruction indicates that these special verses should be inserted just before this concluding formula.

[5] This opening line establishes a protective boundary between the supplicant and negative forces, whether understood as human enemies or spiritual accusers.

[i] This verse comes from Psalm 19:15 and is used to conclude many prayers in Jewish liturgy, including the Amidah (central standing prayer). Its placement here signals the conclusion of this supplicatory section.

[ii] Cf. Talmud Shabbat 119b — By invoking the breath of schoolchildren, this prayer draws on a well-established Jewish tradition that emphasizes the spiritual power and purity of children engaged in Torah study. This reference would resonate strongly with the intended audience, who would understand it as an especially powerful plea before God. | Cf. Fast day liturgy (Ta'anit prayers) — The repetitive structure of 'Answer us' in this prayer mirrors the liturgical patterns used on fast days, suggesting this prayer was intended for times of serious distress when immediate divine intervention was sought. This creates a sense of urgency and intensity in the supplication. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — By concluding with this familiar verse from Psalms, the prayer situates itself within established Jewish liturgical tradition and gives it the formal structure of a complete prayer unit suitable for recitation in communal or individual settings.

[iii] This refers to crying or shedding tears during prayer, which was considered spiritually significant in Jewish mystical tradition. Tears during prayer were often viewed as particularly powerful in accessing divine mercy.

[iv] This phrase refers to the concluding verse of the Amidah prayer, "May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable to You, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer" (Psalm 19:15), which typically marks the end of personal prayers.

[v] This phrase is from Psalm 6:9, expressing the psalmist's confidence that God has heard his prayer, allowing him to dismiss his enemies.

[vi] From Psalm 56:9, this poetic image depicts God collecting the suppliant's tears in a bottle or flask (נאד), a powerful metaphor for divine compassion and remembrance of human suffering.

בְּסִפְרָתֶךָ: יְיָ צְבָאוֹת עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב
לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה:[i] יְיָ צְבָאוֹת
אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה
[iii] הַמֶּלֶךְ [ii] יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ:

flask.[1] Are they not in Your book? The LORD of hosts is with us;[2] the God of Jacob is our stronghold, Selah. O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in You. Save us, O LORD; may the King answer us on the day we call.[A]

[v] [iv] סדר יום ראשון למנחה

Order for Sunday Afternoon Prayer[3]

יאמר פסוקי אנה ה׳ ואחר כך
יאמר זה:

Say the verses of "Ana Hashem" and afterwards say this:

(תהלים יח) לַמְנַצֵּחַ לְעֶבֶד יְיָ
לְדָוִד אֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר לַיְיָ אֶת־דִּבְרֵי
הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת בְּיוֹם הִצִּיל־יְיָ
אוֹתוֹ מִכַּף כָּל־אֹיְבָיו וּמִיַּד
שָׁאוּל: וַיֹּאמַר אֶרְחָמְךָ יְיָ חִזְקִי:
יְיָ סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי וּמְפַלְטִי אֵלִי
צוּרִי אֶחֱסֶה־בּוֹ מָגִנִּי וְקֶרֶן־יִשְׁעִי
מִשְׂגַּבִּי: מְהֻלָּל אֶקְרָא יְיָ וּמִן־אֹיְבַי

(Psalm 18) For the Leader. A Psalm of David the servant of the LORD, who spoke to the LORD the words of this song on the day that the LORD delivered him from the hand of all his enemies, and from the hand of Saul. And he said: I love You, O LORD, my strength. The LORD is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer; my God, my rock, in whom I take refuge; my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my

dering, but in the context of illness might better convey the restless movements of someone in physical discomfort.

[A] Or: "O LORD, save! May the King answer us on the day we call" — This alternative translation more directly follows the Hebrew syntax, with 'הוֹשִׁיעָה' as an imperative ('save!') followed by the subject change to the King in the third person.

[1] This powerful metaphor depicts God collecting and preserving human tears, suggesting that no suffering goes unnoticed. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this image would be particularly comforting to the sick or dying person.

[2] The divine title 'LORD of hosts' (YHVH Tzeva'ot) invokes God as commander of celestial armies, suggesting divine protection during the vulnerable time of illness or approaching death.

[3] This heading introduces the liturgical sequence to be recited during the afternoon (Mincha) prayer on Sunday when visiting the sick. It follows Ma'avar Yabok's systematic organization of prayers by days of the week, with each day having specific morning and afternoon services tailored for those attending to the ill or dying.

[i] This verse from Psalm 46:8 employs the divine name 'LORD of hosts' (יְיָ צְבָאוֹת), emphasizing God's military might as a protector.

[ii] This is an adaptation of Psalm 20:10. The apostrophes before the last three words may indicate a special emphasis or intention (kavvanah) for these words in the prayer context.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 6:9 — By quoting this verse in the context of prayers for the sick, Ma'avar Yabok draws on the tradition of seeking divine protection during physical suffering. The psalm moves from distress to confidence that God has heard the prayer. | Cf. Psalm 56:9 — The image of God collecting tears in a flask would be particularly meaningful in the context of illness and death, suggesting that divine compassion encompasses even the most vulnerable moments of human suffering. | Cf. Psalm 46:8 — This reference invokes divine protection through celestial armies (צְבָאוֹת/hosts), providing spiritual comfort that the sick person is not alone but protected by divine forces. | Cf. Psalm 20:10 — This verse frames the entire prayer with a direct petition for salvation, appropriate for someone in physical distress seeking divine intervention.

[iv] This is a heading indicating the beginning of the afternoon (Mincha) prayer service for the first day of visiting or attending to a sick person. In Ma'avar Yabok, prayers are organized by days of the week, with specific liturgical sequences for morning and afternoon services.

[v] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, root.7.1.1.1.2 — This heading marks the beginning of the afternoon prayer service for Sunday, following the book's systematic arrangement of daily prayers for the sick. These prayers are part of a comprehensive framework that integrates kabbalistic concepts with practical care for the ill.

אוֹשָׁעַ׃ אֲפָפוּנִי חֶבְלֵי־מָוֶת וְנַחֲלֵי
בְלִיַּעַל יבעתוני׃ חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל
סְבָבוּנִי קִדְּמוּנִי מוֹקְשֵׁי מָוֶת׃
בַּצַּר־לִי אֶקְרָא יְיָ וְאֶל־אֱלֹהַי
אֲשַׁוֵּעַ יִשְׁמַע מֵהֵיכָלוֹ קוֹלִי
וְשַׁוְעָתִי לְפָנָיו תָּבוֹא בְאָזְנָיו׃
וַתִּגְעַשׁ וַתִּרְעַשׁ הָאָרֶץ וּמוֹסְדֵי
הָרִים יִרְגָּזוּ וַיִּתְגָּעֲשׁוּ כִּי־חָרָה
לוֹ׃ עָלָה עָשָׁן בְּאַפּוֹ וְאֵשׁ־מִפִּיו
תֹּאכֵל גֶּחָלִים בָּעֲרוּ מִמֶּנּוּ׃ וַיֵּט
שָׁמַיִם וַיֵּרַד וַעֲרָפֶל תַּחַת רַגְלָיו׃
וַיִּרְכַּב עַל־כְּרוּב וַיָּעָף וַיֵּדֶא
עַל־כַּנְפֵי־רוּחַ׃ יָשֶׁת חֹשֶׁךְ סִתְרוֹ
סְבִיבוֹתָיו סֻכָּתוֹ חֶשְׁכַת־מַיִם עָבֵי
שְׁחָקִים׃ מִנֹּגַהּ נֶגְדּוֹ עָבָיו עָבְרוּ
בָּרָד וְגַחֲלֵי־אֵשׁ׃ וַיַּרְעֶם בַּשָּׁמַיִם יְיָ
וְעֶלְיוֹן יִתֵּן קֹלוֹ בָּרָד וְגַחֲלֵי־אֵשׁ׃
וַיִּשְׁלַח חִצָּיו וַיְפִיצֵם וּבְרָקִים
רָב וַיְהֻמֵּם׃ וַיֵּרָאוּ אֲפִיקֵי מַיִם
וַיִּגָּלוּ מוֹסְדוֹת תֵּבֵל מִגַּעֲרָתְךָ יְיָ
מִנִּשְׁמַת רוּחַ אַפֶּךָ׃ יִשְׁלַח מִמָּרוֹם
יִקָּחֵנִי יַמְשֵׁנִי מִמַּיִם רַבִּים׃ יַצִּילֵנִי
מֵאֹיְבִי עָז וּמִשַּׂנְאַי כִּי־אָמְצוּ מִמֶּנִּי׃
יְקַדְּמוּנִי בְיוֹם־אֵידִי וַיְהִי־יְיָ
לְמִשְׁעָן לִי׃ וַיּוֹצִיאֵנִי לַמֶּרְחָב
יְחַלְּצֵנִי כִּי חָפֵץ בִּי׃ יִגְמְלֵנִי
יְיָ כְּצִדְקִי כְּבֹר יָדַי יָשִׁיב לִי׃
כִּי־שָׁמַרְתִּי דַּרְכֵי יְיָ וְלֹא־רָשַׁעְתִּי
מֵאֱלֹהָי׃ כִּי כָל־מִשְׁפָּטָיו לְנֶגְדִּי
וְחֻקֹּתָיו לֹא־אָסִיר מֶנִּי׃ וָאֱהִי
תָמִים עִמּוֹ וָאֶשְׁתַּמֵּר מֵעֲוֹנִי׃
וַיָּשֶׁב־יְיָ לִי כְּצִדְקִי כְּבֹר יָדַי לְנֶגֶד
עֵינָיו׃ עִם־חָסִיד תִּתְחַסָּד עִם־גְּבֶר
תָּמִים תִּתַּמָּם׃ עִם־נָבָר תִּתָּבָרָר
וְעִם־עִקֵּשׁ תִּתַּפָּתָל׃ כִּי־אַתָּה
עַם־עָנִי תוֹשִׁיעַ וְעֵינַיִם רָמוֹת
תַּשְׁפִּיל׃ כִּי־אַתָּה תָּאִיר נֵרִי יְיָ
אֱלֹהַי יַגִּיהַּ חָשְׁכִּי׃ כִּי־בְךָ אָרֻץ
גְּדוּד וּבֵאלֹהַי אֲדַלֶּג־שׁוּר׃ הָאֵל
תָּמִים דַּרְכּוֹ אִמְרַת־יְיָ צְרוּפָה
מָגֵן הוּא לְכֹל הַחֹסִים בּוֹ׃ כִּי מִי
אֱלוֹהַּ מִבַּלְעֲדֵי יְיָ וּמִי צוּר זוּלָתִי
אֱלֹהֵינוּ׃ הָאֵל הַמְאַזְּרֵנִי חָיִל וַיִּתֵּן
תָּמִים דַּרְכִּי׃ מְשַׁוֶּה רַגְלַי כָּאַיָּלוֹת

high tower. Praised, I call upon the LORD, and
I am saved from my enemies. The cords of death
encompassed me, and the floods of wickedness[1] ter-
rified me. The cords of the grave surrounded me;
the snares of death confronted me. In my distress I 395R
called upon the LORD, and cried unto my God; He
heard my voice out of His temple, and my cry came
before Him, into His ears. Then the earth shook and
trembled, the foundations of the mountains quaked
and were shaken, because He was angry. Smoke rose 400R
from His nostrils, and fire from His mouth devoured;
coals were kindled by it. He bowed the heavens and
came down; and thick darkness was under His feet.
And He rode upon a cherub, and flew; and He soared
upon the wings of the wind. He made darkness His 405R
hiding-place, His pavilion round about Him; dark-
ness of waters, thick clouds of the skies.[2] At the
brightness before Him, His thick clouds passed; hail-
stones and coals of fire. The LORD also thundered
in the heavens, and the Most High gave forth His 410R
voice; hailstones and coals of fire. And He sent out
His arrows, and scattered them; and He shot forth
lightnings, and discomfited them. Then the channels
of waters appeared, and the foundations of the world
were laid bare, at Your rebuke, O LORD, at the blast 415R
of the breath of Your nostrils. He sent from on high,
He took me; He drew me out of many waters. He
delivered me from my strong enemy, and from them
that hated me, for they were too mighty for me.
They confronted me in the day of my calamity; but 420R
the LORD was a stay unto me. He brought me forth
also into a large place; He delivered me, because He
delighted in me. The LORD rewarded me according
to my righteousness; according to the cleanness of my
hands has He recompensed me. For I have kept the 425R
ways of the LORD, and have not wickedly departed
from my God. For all His ordinances were before
me, and I put not away His statutes from me. I was
also whole-hearted with Him, and I kept myself from
my iniquity. Therefore has the LORD recompensed 430R
me according to my righteousness, according to the
cleanness of my hands in His eyes. With the mer-
ciful You show Yourself merciful, with the perfect
man You show Yourself perfect; With the pure You

[1]The Hebrew 'nachalei beliyaal' literally means 'streams of worthlessness/wickedness' and refers to overwhelming destructive forces threatening the psalmist.

[2]The piling up of terms for darkness and clouds emphasizes the overwhelming nature of the divine appearance, a common feature in biblical theophanies.

וְעַל בָּמֹתַי יַעֲמִידֵנִי׃ מְלַמֵּד יָדַי
לַמִּלְחָמָה וְנִחֲתָה קֶשֶׁת־נְחוּשָׁה
395 זְרוֹעֹתָי׃ וַתִּתֶּן־לִי מָגֵן יִשְׁעֶךָ
וִימִינְךָ תִסְעָדֵנִי וְעַנְוָתְךָ תַרְבֵּנִי׃
תַּרְחִיב צַעֲדִי תַחְתָּי וְלֹא מָעֲדוּ
קַרְסֻלָּי׃ אֶרְדּוֹף אוֹיְבַי וְאַשִּׂיגֵם
וְלֹא־אָשׁוּב עַד־כַּלּוֹתָם׃ אֶמְחָצֵם
400 וְלֹא־יְכֹלוּ קוּם יִפְּלוּ תַּחַת רַגְלָי׃
וַתְּאַזְּרֵנִי חַיִל לַמִּלְחָמָה תַּכְרִיעַ
קָמַי תַּחְתָּי׃ וְאֹיְבַי נָתַתָּה לִּי
עֹרֶף וּמְשַׂנְאַי אַצְמִיתֵם׃ יְשַׁוְּעוּ
וְאֵין־מוֹשִׁיעַ עַל־יְיָ וְלֹא עָנָם׃
405 וְאֶשְׁחָקֵם כְּעָפָר עַל־פְּנֵי־רוּחַ
כְּטִיט חוּצוֹת אֲרִיקֵם׃ תְּפַלְּטֵנִי
מֵרִיבֵי עָם תְּשִׂימֵנִי לְרֹאשׁ
גּוֹיִם עַם לֹא־יָדַעְתִּי יַעַבְדוּנִי׃
לִשְׁמַע אֹזֶן יִשָּׁמְעוּ לִי בְּנֵי־נֵכָר
410 יְכַחֲשׁוּ־לִי׃ בְּנֵי־נֵכָר יִבֹלּוּ וְיַחְרְגוּ
מִמִּסְגְּרוֹתֵיהֶם׃ חַי־יְיָ וּבָרוּךְ
צוּרִי וְיָרוּם אֱלוֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי׃ הָאֵל
הַנּוֹתֵן נְקָמוֹת לִי וַיַּדְבֵּר עַמִּים
תַּחְתָּי׃ מְפַלְּטִי מֵאֹיְבָי אַף מִן־קָמַי
415 תְּרוֹמְמֵנִי מֵאִישׁ חָמָס תַּצִּילֵנִי׃
עַל־כֵּן אוֹדְךָ בַגּוֹיִם יְיָ וּלְשִׁמְךָ
אֲזַמֵּרָה׃ מגדל [מַגְדִּיל] יְשׁוּעוֹת
מַלְכּוֹ וְעֹשֶׂה חֶסֶד לִמְשִׁיחוֹ לְדָוִד
וּלְזַרְעוֹ עַד־עוֹלָם׃ [i]

show Yourself pure;[1] and with the crooked You show 435R
Yourself subtle. For You save the afflicted people;
but the haughty eyes You bring down. For You light
my lamp; the LORD my God illumines my darkness.
For by You I run upon a troop; and by my God do I
scale a wall. As for God, His way is perfect; the word 440R
of the LORD is tried; He is a shield unto all them
that take refuge in Him. For who is God, save the
LORD? And who is a Rock, except our God? The
God who girds me with strength, and makes my way
perfect; Who makes my feet like hinds', and sets me 445R
upon my high places; Who trains my hands for war,
so that my arms bend a bow of bronze. You have
also given me the shield of Your salvation, and Your
right hand has supported me; Your gentleness has
made me great. You have enlarged my steps under 450R
me, and my feet have not slipped. I have pursued
my enemies, and overtaken them; neither did I turn
back till they were consumed. I have smitten them
through, so that they are not able to rise; they are
fallen under my feet. For You have girded me with 455R
strength unto the battle; You have subdued under
me those that rose up against me. You have also
made my enemies turn their backs unto me, and I
have destroyed them that hate me. They cried, but
there was none to save; even unto the LORD, but 460R
He answered them not. Then I beat them small as
the dust before the wind; I cast them out as the
mire of the streets. You have delivered me from the
contentions of the people; You have made me the
head of nations; a people whom I have not known 465R
serve me. As soon as they hear of me, they obey me;
the sons of the stranger[2] submit themselves unto me.
The sons of the stranger fade away, and come trem-
bling out of their strongholds. The LORD lives, and
blessed be my Rock; and exalted be the God of my 470R
salvation; Even the God that executes vengeance for
me, and subdues peoples under me. He delivers me
from my enemies; indeed, You lift me up above those

[1] This section demonstrates the biblical principle that God responds to humans according to their own moral qualities, a concept that would resonate with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation.

[2] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, 'sons of the stranger' (bnei nekhar) might be interpreted metaphorically as hostile spiritual forces that threaten the sick person.

[i] Cf. Book of Psalms — This is a complete rendering of Psalm 18, which appears in Ma'avar Yabok as part of a structured liturgical sequence for the sick and dying. The psalm recounts David's thanksgiving to God for deliverance from enemies, making it appropriate for someone in distress seeking divine protection and salvation.

that rise up against me; You deliver me from the violent man. Therefore I will give thanks unto You, 475R
O LORD, among the nations, and will sing praises unto Your name. Great salvation gives He to His king;[1] and shows loving-kindness to His anointed, to David and to his seed, for evermore.

(תורה) וְיִתֶּן לְךָ הָאֱלֹהִים
מִטַּל הַשָּׁמַיִם וּמִשְׁמַנֵּי הָאָרֶץ
וְרֹב דָּגָן וְתִירֹשׁ: [i] וַיַּעֲקֹב הָלַךְ
לְדַרְכּוֹ וַיִּפְגְּעוּ בוֹ מַלְאֲכֵי
אֱלֹהִים: [ii] וַיֹּאמֶר יַעֲקֹב כַּאֲשֶׁר
רָאָם מַחֲנֵה אֱלֹהִים זֶה וַיִּקְרָא שֵׁם
הַמָּקוֹם הַהוּא מַחֲנָיִם: [iii] אֱלֹהֵי
אָבִי אַבְרָהָם וֵאלֹהֵי אָבִי יִצְחָק
יְיָ הָאֹמֵר אֵלַי שׁוּב לְאַרְצְךָ
וּלְמוֹלַדְתְּךָ וְאֵיטִיבָה עִמָּךְ:
קָטֹנְתִּי מִכֹּל הַחֲסָדִים וּמִכָּל הָאֱמֶת
אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתָ אֶת עַבְדֶּךָ: הַצִּילֵנִי נָא
מִיַּד אָחִי מִיַּד עֵשָׂו כִּי יָרֵא אָנֹכִי
אֹתוֹ [iv] פֶּן יָבוֹא וְהִכַּנִי אֵם עַל

(Torah) May God give you from the dew of heaven 480R
and the fat places of the earth, and abundance of grain and wine: And Jacob went on his way, and angels of God encountered him.[A] And Jacob said when he saw them, "This is God's camp,"[2] and he called the name of that place Mahanaim.[3] O God of 485R
my father Abraham and God of my father Isaac, the LORD who said to me, "Return to your land and to your birthplace, and I will do good with you." I am unworthy of all the kindnesses and all the truth[B] that You have done for Your servant. Deliver me, please, 490R
from the hand of my brother, from the hand of Esau, for I fear him, lest he come and strike me, mother with children.[4] And You said, "I will surely do good

[A] Or: "and angels of God met him" — The Hebrew verb פגע has a range of meanings including 'meet,' 'encounter,' or even 'come upon.' This alternate translation maintains the sense of the divine beings actively engaging with Jacob while using more common English phrasing.

[B] Or: "I have become small from all the kindnesses and all the faithfulness" — The Hebrew קָטֹנְתִּי literally means 'I have become small' or 'diminished,' which poetically expresses humility in the face of divine generosity. This more literal translation preserves the striking imagery of Jacob being 'diminished' by God's overwhelming goodness, rather than simply being 'unworthy.'

[1] The final verse uses 'magdil' (makes great) in the written text but is traditionally read as 'migdol' (tower of) in some contexts, though both convey divine magnification of salvation.

[2] The Hebrew מַחֲנֵה אֱלֹהִים (machaneh Elohim) refers to an encampment of divine beings or angels. In the context of prayers for the sick or dying, this image of divine encampment suggests spiritual protection surrounding the individual.

[3] Literally 'two camps,' symbolizing the meeting point between human and divine realms. This is especially significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as it represents the threshold between life and death where these realms intersect.

[4] This Hebrew idiom (אֵם עַל בָּנִים) expresses complete destruction, suggesting the annihilation of an entire family. In the prayer context for the sick, it represents the fear of complete vulnerability that illness can bring.

[i] This verse (Genesis 27:28) is from Isaac's blessing to Jacob, which begins the collection of verses about Jacob in this prayer sequence. The blessing of abundance from heaven and earth represents divine provision during both life and the transition of death.

[ii] This verse from Genesis 32:1 is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok as it describes Jacob's encounter with angels immediately before crossing the Yabok River, the event that gives the book its title and central metaphor.

[iii] The name 'Mahanaim' means 'two camps' and refers to Jacob's encounter with angels before meeting Esau (Genesis 32:1-2). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this name has special significance as it connects to the book's central metaphor of 'crossing over' from life to death, with the two camps representing the human and divine realms that meet at this transition.

[iv] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, Jacob's prayer for deliverance from his brother Esau takes on added significance as a metaphor for protection from spiritual adversaries during the soul's transition at death.

בָּנִים: וְאַתָּה אָמַרְתָּ הֵיטֵב אֵיטִיב
עִמָּךְ וְשַׂמְתִּי אֶת זַרְעֲךָ כְּחוֹל הַיָּם
אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִסָּפֵר מֵרֹב: לֹא אֲשַׁלֵּחֲךָ
כִּי אִם בֵּרַכְתָּנִי:[i][ii]

with you, and make your offspring like the sand of the sea, which cannot be counted for multitude." I will not send you away unless you bless me.[A] 495R

(נביאים) מֵקִים מֵעָפָר דָּל
מֵאַשְׁפֹּת יָרִים אֶבְיוֹן[iii] לְהוֹשִׁיב עִם
נְדִיבִים וְכִסֵּא כָבוֹד יַנְחִלֵם: כִּי
לַיְיָ מְצֻקֵי אֶרֶץ וַיָּשֶׁת עֲלֵיהֶם תֵּבֵל:
רַגְלֵי חֲסִידָו יִשְׁמֹר וּרְשָׁעִים בַּחֹשֶׁךְ
יִדָּמוּ[iv] כִּי לֹא בְכֹחַ יִגְבַּר אִישׁ:
כִּי לֹא יִטֹּשׁ יְיָ אֶת עַמּוֹ בַּעֲבוּר
שְׁמוֹ הַגָּדוֹל[v] כִּי הוֹאִיל יְיָ לַעֲשׂוֹת
אֶתְכֶם לוֹ לְעָם: יִשְׁפֹּט יְיָ בֵּינִי

(From Prophets) He raises the poor from the dust, and lifts the needy from the ash heap,[1] to seat them with nobles, and He gives them a throne of honor as an inheritance. For the foundations of the earth belong to the LORD,[2] and He has set the world upon them. He guards the feet of His faithful ones,[3] but the wicked are silenced in darkness, for not by strength does a person prevail. For the LORD will not abandon His people for the sake of 500R 505R

[A] Or: "I will not let you go until you bless me" — This alternative more directly conveys the sense of physical holding or grasping implied in the context of Jacob's wrestling with the angel. The phrase 'let you go' better captures the immediacy and physicality of the struggle than 'send you away,' which might suggest a more formal dismissal.

[1] These verses from Hannah's prayer establish a theological framework of divine reversal of fortune, which in Ma'avar Yabok extends to the ultimate reversal—the transformation of death into spiritual elevation.

[2] The Hebrew 'מְצֻקֵי אֶרֶץ' (foundations of the earth) can also be interpreted as 'the distressed of the earth,' creating a dual meaning that God possesses both the physical world and its suffering inhabitants.

[3] In kabbalistic interpretation, 'feet' (רַגְלֵי) often symbolize the lowest spiritual levels, suggesting God's protection extends even to the most basic aspects of human existence.

[i] This verse (Genesis 32:27) is from Jacob's wrestling with the angel at the Yabok River crossing. This struggle and Jacob's insistence on a blessing before releasing the angel is central to the metaphor of Ma'avar Yabok, representing the soul's struggle and transformation during the transition of death.

[ii] Cf. Genesis 32:1-2 — This biblical passage is the source text for the quoted verses and provides the foundation for Ma'avar Yabok's central metaphor of crossing between worlds. The 'two camps' represent the meeting point between human and divine realms, which in the book's context symbolizes the threshold between life and death. | Cf. Genesis 32:22-32 — Though only the final verse is directly quoted, this entire episode is foundational to Ma'avar Yabok, giving the book its title and central metaphor. Jacob's struggle at the river represents the soul's struggle at the threshold between life and death, and the blessing and transformation he receives prefigures the spiritual transformation the soul undergoes in this transition. | Cf. Genesis 27:28 — This blessing is included to invoke divine abundance and protection for the ill person. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it represents the continuity of divine blessing that extends from this life to the next, suggesting that God's provision continues even through the transition of death. | Cf. Genesis 32:10-13 — Jacob's prayer serves as a model for the ill or dying person, demonstrating proper humility before God, acknowledgment of divine protection and goodness in the past, and appropriate petition based on God's promises. In Ma'avar Yabok, this prayer is particularly apt as it was offered at a moment of extreme vulnerability and transition, paralleling the situation of those approaching death.

[iii] This verse is from Hannah's prayer (1 Samuel 2:8), which became a foundational text for Jewish understanding of divine sovereignty and reversal of fortune. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it emphasizes God's power to transform human conditions, particularly relevant to discussions of illness and death.

[iv] This continues Hannah's prayer (1 Samuel 2:9), emphasizing divine protection for the righteous and judgment for the wicked. In Ma'avar Yabok, this reinforces the theological framework that proper spiritual practice provides protection during life transitions.

[v] From 1 Samuel 12:22, this verse assures God's continued faithfulness to Israel despite difficulties, a comforting message in the context of illness and approaching death.

וּבֵינֶךָ וּנְקָמַנִי יְיָ מִמֶּךָּ וְיָדִי לֹא
תִהְיֶה בָּךְ׃ [i] אִם יְיָ הֱסִיתְךָ בִי יָרַח
מִנְחָה[ii] וְאִם בְּנֵי הָאָדָם אֲרוּרִים
450 הֵם לְפָנַי יְיָ כִּי גֵרְשׁוּנִי הַיּוֹם
מֵהִסְתַּפֵּחַ בְּנַחֲלַת יְיָ: וְהִנֵּה כַּאֲשֶׁר
נָדְלָה נַפְשְׁךָ הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה בְּעֵינָיו כֵּן
תִּגְדַּל נַפְשִׁי בְּעֵינֵי יְיָ[iii] וַיְצַלֵּנִי
מִכָּל צָרָה: יְהוָה הוּא הַטּוֹב בְּעֵינָו
455 יַעֲשֶׂה: מִי אָנֹכִי אֲדֹנָי יְיָ וּמִי בֵיתִי
כִּי הֲבִיאוֹתַנִי עַד הֲלֹם׃ [iv] וַתְּקַטֵּן
עוֹד זֹאת בְּעֵינֶיךָ אֲדֹנָי יְיָ וַתְּדַבֵּר
גַּם אֶל בֵּית עַבְדְּךָ לְמֵרָחוֹק וְזֹאת
[vi] [v] תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהִים׃

His great name, because the LORD has been pleased to make you His people. May the LORD judge between me and you, and may the LORD avenge me against you, but my hand shall not be against you. If the LORD has incited you against me, let 510R
Him accept an offering;[A] but if it is people, cursed are they before the LORD,[1] for they have driven me out today from sharing in the inheritance of the LORD. And behold, just as your life was precious in my eyes this day, so may my life be precious in the 515R
eyes of the LORD,[2] and may He rescue me from all trouble. The LORD—may He do what is good in His eyes. Who am I, O Lord GOD, and what is my house, that You have brought me this far? And even this was insignificant in Your eyes, O Lord GOD, for 520R
You have spoken also about Your servant's house for a distant future—and this is the instruction for

[A] Or: "If the LORD has stirred you against me, may He smell an offering" — The verb 'יָרַח' literally means 'to smell' rather than 'accept,' reflecting the ancient conception of sacrifice as creating a pleasing aroma for the deity. This more literal translation preserves the sensory aspect of the ritual offering that might be relevant to Ma'avar Yabok's detailed treatment of ritual practices.

[1] This passage distinguishes between suffering that comes directly from God (which requires ritual offering) versus suffering caused by human agents (which requires divine justice)—a distinction important to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of illness.

[2] The Hebrew term 'נַפְשִׁי' (my life/soul) has deeper implications than simply physical life, referring to the essence of one's being that continues beyond death—a central concern of Ma'avar Yabok.

[i] From David's words to Saul (1 Samuel 24:13), this expresses leaving justice to God rather than taking personal vengeance. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this represents the proper attitude of acceptance toward divine judgment.

[ii] From 1 Samuel 26:19, part of David's appeal to Saul. The phrase 'יָרַח מִנְחָה' (let Him accept an offering) suggests that even divine-induced suffering can be addressed through proper ritual response—a key concept in Ma'avar Yabok.

[iii] From David's words to Saul (1 Samuel 26:24), expressing hope that God will value his life as he has valued Saul's. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the hope that showing mercy to others will result in divine mercy for oneself.

[iv] From David's prayer after Nathan's prophecy (2 Samuel 7:18), expressing humility before divine favor. In Ma'avar Yabok, this models the proper humble response to divine blessing and providence.

[v] From 2 Samuel 7:19, concluding David's prayer. The phrase 'תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם' (instruction/law of humanity) is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, suggesting that proper response to mortality is the fundamental human spiritual teaching.

[vi] Cf. Hannah's Prayer (1 Samuel 2:1-10) — Hannah's prayer of thanksgiving for divine reversal of fortune is cited here to emphasize God's sovereignty over human conditions, particularly relevant to discussions of illness and transformation through death. The verses establish that divine power, not human strength, determines outcomes, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation rather than merely physical treatment. | Cf. David's words to Saul — David's refusal to harm Saul despite being persecuted models the spiritual virtue of leaving judgment to God rather than seeking personal vengeance. In Ma'avar Yabok, this attitude represents the proper response to suffering: accepting divine judgment while seeking merciful intervention through appropriate ritual means rather than rebellion. | Cf. David's prayer after Nathan's prophecy — David's expression of humility before divine favor models the proper spiritual posture when receiving blessing. The concluding phrase 'תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם' (instruction for humanity) is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context, suggesting that understanding one's place in divine providence—especially facing mortality—constitutes fundamental human spiritual wisdom.

humanity, O Lord GOD.[A]

(תהלים) הָאֵל הַנּוֹתֵן נְקָמוֹת
לִי וַיַּדְבֵּר עַמִּים תַּחְתָּי: מְפַלְטִי
מֵאוֹיְבָי אַף מִן קָמַי תְּרוֹמְמֵנִי מֵאִישׁ
חָמָס תַּצִּילֵנִי: יַעַנְךָ יְיָ בְּיוֹם צָרָה
יְשַׂגֶּבְךָ שֵׁם אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב: [i] יִשְׁלַח
עֶזְרְךָ מִקֹּדֶשׁ וּמִצִּיּוֹן יִסְעָדֶךָּ: יִזְכֹּר
כָּל מִנְחֹתֶךָ וְעוֹלָתְךָ יְדַשְּׁנֶה סֶלָה:
יִתֶּן לְךָ כִלְבָבֶךָ וְכָל עֲצָתְךָ יְמַלֵּא:
נְרַנְּנָה בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ וּבְשֵׁם אֱלֹהֵינוּ
נִדְגֹּל יְמַלֵּא יְיָ כָּל מִשְׁאֲלוֹתֶיךָ:
עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי הוֹשִׁיעַ יְיָ מְשִׁיחוֹ
יַעֲנֵהוּ מִשְּׁמֵי קָדְשׁוֹ בִּגְבֻרוֹת יֶשַׁע
יְמִינוֹ: אֵלֶּה בָרֶכֶב וְאֵלֶּה בַסּוּסִים
וַאֲנַחְנוּ בְּשֵׁם יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ נַזְכִּיר:
הֵמָּה כָרְעוּ וְנָפָלוּ וַאֲנַחְנוּ קַמְנוּ
וַנִּתְעוֹדָד: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה הַמֶּלֶךְ
יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ: בְּךָ בָּטְחוּ
אֲבֹתֵינוּ בָּטְחוּ וַתְּפַלְּטֵמוֹ: אֵלֶיךָ
זָעֲקוּ וְנִמְלָטוּ בְּךָ בָטְחוּ וְלֹא
בוֹשׁוּ: אַל תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי כִּי צָרָה
קְרוֹבָה כִּי אֵין עוֹזֵר: [ii] וְאַתָּה יְיָ
אַל תִּרְחַק אֲיָלוּתִי לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה:
עִיֵּנִי תָּמִיד אֶל יְיָ כִּי הוּא יוֹצִיא
מֵרֶשֶׁת רַגְלָי: אֱלֹהַי בְּךָ בָטַחְתִּי
אַל אֵבוֹשָׁה אַל יַעַלְצוּ אֹיְבַי לִי:
צָרוֹת לְבָבִי הִרְחִיבוּ מְמִצוּקוֹתַי
הוֹצִיאֵנִי: בְּקַרְבִּ עָלַי מָרְעִים
לְאָכֵל אֶת בְּשָׂרִי צָרַי וְאֹיְבַי לִי
הֵמָּה כָשְׁלוּ וְנָפָלוּ: אַחַת שָׁאַלְתִּי
מֵאֵת יְיָ אוֹתָהּ אֲבַקֵּשׁ: שִׁבְתִּי בְּבֵית

(Psalms) The God who grants me vengeance and subdues peoples under me. My deliverer from my enemies; You lift me above those who rise against me; from the violent man You rescue me. May the LORD answer you in the day of trouble; may the name of the God of Jacob set you on high. May He send you help from the sanctuary, and strengthen you from Zion. May He remember all your offerings, and accept your burnt sacrifice. Selah. May He grant you according to your heart's desire, and fulfill all your counsel. We will rejoice in your salvation, and in the name of our God we will set up our banners![1] May the LORD fulfill all your petitions. Now I know that the LORD saves His anointed; He will answer him from His holy heaven with the saving strength of His right hand. Some trust in chariots, and some in horses; but we will remember the name of the LORD our God.[2] They have bowed down and fallen; but we have risen and stand upright. Save, LORD! May the King answer us when we call. In You our fathers trusted; they trusted, and You delivered them. They cried to You and were rescued; in You they trusted and were not put to shame. Do not be far from me, for trouble is near, for there is none to help. But You, O LORD, do not be far off! O my Strength, come quickly to help me! My eyes are ever toward the LORD, for He shall release my feet from the net. My God, I trust in You; let me not be ashamed, let not my enemies triumph over me. The troubles of my heart have enlarged; bring

[A] Or: "and this is the law of human existence, O Lord GOD" — The phrase 'תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם' could be interpreted more broadly as referring to the fundamental principle governing human existence rather than simply an instruction. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's focus on death and transition, this reading emphasizes mortality and proper response to it as the defining condition of humanity.

[1] The Hebrew verb 'נִדְגֹּל' (we will set up banners) shares the same root as 'דגל' (flag/banner) but can also connote distinction or prominence. In the context of these prayer sequences for the sick, it represents a declaration of allegiance to divine power rather than natural remedies.

[2] This verse expresses a central theological position in Ma'avar Yabok, contrasting reliance on material remedies with trust in divine power, which is particularly relevant in contexts of illness and approaching death.

[i] This opening verse from Psalm 20 begins a section that is specifically prescribed in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation during times of illness or distress.

[ii] This verse from Psalm 22:12 appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences for the sick and dying, expressing the sense of urgency and vulnerability experienced during serious illness.

יְיָ כָּל יְמֵי חַיַּי לַחֲזוֹת בְּנֹעַם יְיָ
וּלְבַקֵּר בְּהֵיכָלוֹ: אַל תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ
מִמֶּנִּי אַל תַּט בְּאַף עַבְדֶּךָ עֶזְרָתִי
הָיִיתָ אַל תִּטְּשֵׁנִי וְאַל תַּעַזְבֵנִי
אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי: כִּי אָבִי וְאִמִּי עֲזָבוּנִי
וַיהוָה יַאַסְפֵנִי: שְׁמַע קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנַי
בְּשַׁוְּעִי אֵלֶיךָ בְּנָשְׂאִי יָדַי אֶל דְּבִיר
קָדְשֶׁךָ: קַוֵּה אֶל יְיָ חֲזַק וְיַאֲמֵץ
לִבֶּךָ וְקַוֵּה אֶל יְיָ: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ כִּי
שָׁמַע קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי: יְיָ עֻזִּי לְעַמּוֹ
יִתֵּן יְיָ יְבָרֵךְ אֶת עַמּוֹ בַשָּׁלוֹם:
אֵלֶיךָ יְיָ אֶקְרָא וְאֶל יְיָ אֶתְחַנָּן:
שְׁמַע יְיָ וְחָנֵּנִי יְיָ הֱיֵה עֹזֵר לִי: כִּי
סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי אָתָּה וּלְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ
תַּנְחֵנִי וּתְנַהֲלֵנִי: תּוֹצִיאֵנִי מֵרֶשֶׁת
זוּ טָמְנוּ לִי כִּי אַתָּה מָעוּזִּי: בְּיָדְךָ
אַפְקִיד רוּחִי פָּדִיתָה אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל
אֱמֶת: [i] אָגִילָה וְאֶשְׂמְחָה בְּחַסְדֶּךָ
אֲשֶׁר רָאִיתָ אֶת עָנְיִי יָדַעְתָּ בְּצָרוֹת
נַפְשִׁי: חָנֵּנִי יְיָ כִּי צַר לִי עָשְׁשָׁה
בְכַעַס עֵינִי נַפְשִׁי וּבִטְנִי: [ii]

me out of my distresses![1] When evildoers came upon me to devour my flesh, my adversaries and my foes, they stumbled and fell. One thing I have asked of the LORD, that will I seek: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to behold the beauty of the LORD, and to inquire in His temple. Do not hide Your face from me; do not turn Your servant away in anger; You have been my help; do not leave me nor forsake me, O God of my salvation. For my father and my mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take me in. Hear, O LORD, the voice of my supplications when I cry to You, when I lift up my hands toward Your holy sanctuary. Wait for the LORD; be strong, and let your heart take courage; wait for the LORD. Blessed be the LORD, for He has heard the voice of my supplications! The LORD will give strength to His people; the LORD will bless His people with peace. To You, O LORD, I call, and to the LORD I make supplication. Hear, O LORD, and be gracious to me; LORD, be my helper. For You are my rock and my fortress; for Your name's sake You will lead me and guide me. You will bring me out of the net they have secretly laid for me, for You are my stronghold. Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth.[2] I will be glad and rejoice in Your mercy, for You have

555R 560R 565R 570R 575R

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'צָרוֹת לְבָבִי הִרְחִיבוּ' literally means 'the troubles of my heart have enlarged/expanded,' creating a paradoxical image that could be interpreted as either the heart being enlarged by troubles (negatively) or the heart's capacity being expanded through suffering (potentially positive). This ambiguity aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's view that suffering can serve as spiritual purification.

[2] This verse (Psalm 31:6) holds special significance in Jewish traditions surrounding death and is recommended in Ma'avar Yabok to be recited at the moment of death as an expression of complete surrender to God.

[i] This verse from Psalm 31:6 is highlighted in Ma'avar Yabok as particularly important for deathbed recitation, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited this verse at his martyrdom, and of Jesus in the Christian tradition. It represents the ultimate act of surrender to divine care.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 20 — Psalm 20 appears in Ma'avar Yabok as one of several psalms specifically recommended for recitation by or for the sick. Its themes of divine support in times of trouble, heavenly assistance, and confidence in ultimate divine salvation make it particularly relevant for those experiencing serious illness. | Cf. Psalm 22 — Psalm 22 contains expressions of both profound suffering and ultimate hope, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness as both a challenge and an opportunity for spiritual transformation. The specific verses included here express the vulnerability of the sufferer alongside confidence in divine deliverance. | Cf. Psalm 27 — These verses from Psalm 27 focus on seeking divine presence and protection, expressing the psalmist's desire to dwell in God's house. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they represent the ideal spiritual focus for those facing illness or approaching death—turning toward divine presence rather than dwelling on physical suffering. | Cf. Psalm 31 — Psalm 31 is particularly significant in Jewish deathbed practices. The verse 'Into Your hand I commit my spirit' (31:6) is highlighted in Ma'avar Yabok as ideally recited at the moment of death, following the example of Rabbi Akiva who recited this verse during his martyrdom.

considered my trouble; You have known the troubles of my soul. Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am in distress; my eye wastes away with grief, yes, my soul and my body. 580R

(כתובים) צָעַק לִבָּם אֶל
אֲדֹנָי חוֹמַת בַּת צִיּוֹן[i] הוֹרִידִי
כַנַּחַל דִּמְעָה[ii] יוֹמָם וָלָיְלָה אַל
תִּתְּנִי פּוּגַת לָךְ אַל תִּדֹּם בַּת
עֵינָךְ: קוּמִי רֹנִּי בַלַּיְלָה לְרֹאשׁ
אַשְׁמֻרוֹת שִׁפְכִי כַמַּיִם לִבֵּךְ נֹכַח
פְּנֵי אֲדֹנָי שְׂאִי אֵלָיו כַּפַּיִךְ עַל
נֶפֶשׁ עוֹלָלַיִךְ הָעֲטוּפִים בְּרָעָב
בְּרֹאשׁ כָּל חוּצוֹת:[iii] שָׁמְעוּ כִּי
נֶאֱנָחָה אָנִי אֵין מְנַחֵם לִי כָּל
אֹיְבַי שָׁמְעוּ רָעָתִי שָׂשׂוּ כִּי אַתָּה
עָשִׂיתָ הֵבֵאתָ יוֹם קָרָאתָ וְיִהְיוּ
כָמוֹנִי: זְכָר עָנְיִי וּמְרוּדִי לַעֲנָה
וָרֹאשׁ:[iv] זָכוֹר תִּזְכּוֹר וְתָשׁוֹחַ עָלַי
נַפְשִׁי: זֹאת אָשִׁיב אֶל לִבִּי עַל כֵּן
אוֹחִיל:[v] חַסְדֵי יְיָ כִּי לֹא תָמְנוּ
כִּי לֹא כָלוּ רַחֲמָיו:[vi] חֲדָשִׁים
לַבְּקָרִים רַבָּה אֱמוּנָתֶךָ: חֶלְקִי יְיָ
אָמְרָה נַפְשִׁי עַל כֵּן אוֹחִיל לוֹ:

(From the Writings) Their heart cried out to the Lord, "O wall of the daughter of Zion, let tears run down like a river day and night; give yourself no rest,[A] let not the apple of your eye cease." Arise, cry out in the night, at the beginning of the watches;[B] pour out your heart like water before the face of the Lord. Lift your hands to Him for the lives of your young children, who faint from hunger at the head of every street. They heard that I sigh; there is no one to comfort me. All my enemies have heard of my trouble; they are glad that You have done it. You have brought the day You called for, and they shall be like me. Remember my affliction and my wandering, the wormwood and the gall. My soul remembers them well and is bowed down within me.[C] This I recall to my mind, therefore I have hope:[1] Through the Lord's mercies we are not consumed, because His compassions fail not. They are new every morning;[2] great is Your faithfulness. 585R 590R 595R 600R

[A] Or: "allow yourself no respite" — The Hebrew 'pugat' refers specifically to a pause or cessation, so 'respite' might better capture the nuance that the wall/daughter of Zion should not take even a momentary break from her mourning.

[B] Or: "in the night, at the start of each watch" — The term 'ashmurot' refers to the divisions of the night watch, and this alternate more clearly conveys the idea of crying out repeatedly at the beginning of each watch period throughout the night.

[C] Or: "and sinks down within me" — The Hebrew 'tashoach' has the sense of sinking or being depressed, which might convey the emotional state more vividly than 'bowed down.'

[1] This statement begins a remarkable section of hope amid profound despair. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this shift from lamentation to hope serves as a spiritual model for the sick and dying to find comfort even in their darkest moments.

[2] The Hebrew term 'chadashim labekarim' emphasizes that God's mercies are not merely renewed but made completely new each day, providing a powerful theological foundation for daily hope regardless of previous suffering.

[i] "O wall of the daughter of Zion"—this personification of Jerusalem's walls as a mourning woman is a powerful poetic device in Lamentations, representing both the physical structure of the destroyed city and the community that has been shattered.

[ii] The command to "let tears run down like a river" uses the feminine imperative form, addressing the personified wall of Jerusalem directly as if it were a grieving woman.

[iii] This vivid description of children fainting from hunger at street corners evokes the horrific suffering during Jerusalem's siege and destruction, particularly emphasizing the plight of the most vulnerable.

[iv] "Wormwood and gall"—bitter substances that symbolize extreme suffering. Wormwood (laanah) is a bitter herb, while rosh (often translated as 'gall') likely refers to a bitter, poisonous plant.

[v] This verse marks a pivotal turning point in the passage, shifting from lamentation to hope, as the speaker begins to recall reasons for faith despite suffering.

[vi] One of the most hopeful verses in Lamentations, affirming that despite devastation, God's mercies and compassions remain. This verse forms the basis for several Jewish liturgical prayers and songs.

530 טוֹב יְיָ לְקַוָּו לְנֶפֶשׁ תִּדְרְשֶׁנּוּ: טוֹב
וְיָחִיל וְדוּמָם לִתְשׁוּעַת יְיָ: טוֹב
לַגֶּבֶר כִּי יִשָּׂא עֹל בִּנְעוּרָיו: יֵשֵׁב
בָּדָד וְיִדֹּם כִּי נָטַל עָלָיו:[i] יִתֵּן
בֶּעָפָר פִּיהוּ אוּלַי יֵשׁ תִּקְוָה: כִּי
535 לֹא יִזְנַח לְעוֹלָם אֲדֹנָי: כִּי אִם
הוֹגָה וְרִחַם כְּרֹב חֲסָדָיו: עִנִּי
נִגְרָה וְלֹא תִדְמֶה מֵאֵין הֲפֻגוֹת:
עַד יַשְׁקִיף וְיֵרֶא יְיָ מִשָּׁמָיִם:
עֵינִי עוֹלְלָה לְנַפְשִׁי מִכֹּל בְּנוֹת
540 עִירִי: צוֹד צָדוּנִי כַּצִּפּוֹר אֹיְבַי
חִנָּם: צָמְתוּ בַבּוֹר חַיָּי וַיַּדּוּ אֶבֶן
בִּי: צָפוּ מַיִם עַל רֹאשִׁי אָמַרְתִּי
נִגְזָרְתִּי: קָרָאתִי שִׁמְךָ יְיָ מִבּוֹר
תַּחְתִּיּוֹת:[ii] קוֹלִי שָׁמָעְתָּ אַל תַּעְלֵם
545 אָזְנְךָ לְרִוָחָתִי לְשַׁוְעָתִי: קָרַבְתָּ
בְּיוֹם אֶקְרָאֶךָּ אָמַרְתָּ אַל תִּירָא:[iii]

"The Lord is my portion," says my soul, "Therefore I hope in Him." The Lord is good to those who wait for Him, to the soul who seeks Him. It is good that 605R
one should hope and wait quietly for the salvation of the Lord. It is good for a man to bear the yoke in his youth.[1] Let him sit alone and keep silent, because God has laid it on him. Let him put his mouth in the dust;[A] there may yet be hope. For the 610R
Lord will not cast off forever.[2] Though He causes grief, yet He will show compassion according to the multitude of His mercies. My eye flows and does not cease, without interruption, until the Lord looks down and sees from heaven. My eyes bring suffering 615R
to my soul[B] because of all the daughters of my city. My enemies hunted me down like a bird without cause. They silenced my life in the pit and threw a stone at me. Waters flowed over my head; I said, "I am cut off!" I called on Your name, O Lord, from 620R
the lowest pit. You have heard my voice: "Do not hide Your ear from my sighing, from my cry." You drew near on the day I called on You,[3] and said,

[A] Or: "Let him press his mouth to the dust" — This alternative more vividly conveys the physical posture of complete humiliation and submission described in the text.

[B] Or: "My eyes afflict my soul" — The Hebrew verb 'olela' has the sense of inflicting or causing harm, and this more direct translation better conveys how the act of witnessing suffering becomes itself a source of torment.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse takes on special significance, suggesting that early experiences of suffering and discipline prepare one spiritually for life's greater challenges, including illness and death.

[2] This theological assertion that divine rejection is temporary rather than permanent provides essential comfort in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death, suggesting that even death itself is not final abandonment but a transition.

[3] This concluding note of divine responsiveness and comfort brings the passage full circle, suggesting that sincere prayer, even from 'the lowest pit,' receives divine attention and response—a key message for those facing death.

[i] "Because God has laid it on him"—the Hebrew is more ambiguous, literally "because he has taken [it] upon himself," which could mean either that God has imposed the suffering or that the person has willingly accepted it.

[ii] "From the lowest pit"—the Hebrew 'bor tachtiyot' suggests the deepest dungeon or cistern, metaphorically representing the nadir of suffering and despair, sometimes associated with Sheol (the underworld).

[iii] Cf. Lamentations — Ma'avar Yabok includes this passage to provide those facing death with a biblical model of profound grief that nevertheless maintains faith in divine mercy. The careful selection of verses creates a therapeutic progression from despair to hope. | Cf. Psalm 102 — This passage from Lamentations echoes the movement in Psalm 102 from deep despair to hope in divine mercy. Both texts present suffering as temporary and emphasize that even extreme distress does not indicate complete divine abandonment. | Cf. Zohar — This passage's emphasis on the spiritual benefits of suffering ('It is good for a man to bear the yoke in his youth') resonates with kabbalistic teachings about suffering as a means of spiritual purification rather than mere punishment, a theme central to Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This Lamentations passage exemplifies the pattern of deathbed confession encouraged in Ma'avar Yabok: acknowledgment of suffering, expression of despair, recollection of divine mercy, and concluding with renewed hope and divine proximity.

"Do not fear!"

קַשּׁוּבוֹת תִּהְיֶינָה אָזְנֶיךָ לְשֶׁפֶךְ שִׂיחֵנוּ.[i] רוֹן שָׂפָה קַבֵּל בְּרֵיחַ נִיחוֹחֵינוּ.[ii] שַׁחֲרְנוּךָ[iii] מָגִנֵּנוּ כִּי בְךָ מִבְטָחֵנוּ: וְשִׁמְךָ עָלֵינוּ נִקְרָא אַל תַּנִּיחֵנוּ: יִהְיוּ לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי לְפָנֶיךָ יְהוָה צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי:[iv]

May Your ears be attentive to our outpouring of prayer. Accept the song of our lips as a pleasing fragrance:[1] We seek You early, our Shield, for in You is our trust: Your name is called upon us, do not forsake us:[2] May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, O LORD, my Rock and my Redeemer.[3] 625R 630R

סדר יום שני[v]

Order for the Second Day[4]

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[vi] הכתובים

He should recite the "Ana Hashem" verse[5]s written

[1]This sacrificial imagery is significant within Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, where prayer serves as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings. The text consistently portrays proper prayer as creating the same spiritual effects as the ancient sacrificial system.

[2]The original includes an implicit reference to the covenant relationship between God and Israel, where God's name being 'called upon us' indicates both protection and belonging. This increases the emotional weight of the plea not to be forsaken.

[3]This final verse is a direct quote from Psalm 19:15, a common closing formula in Jewish prayer that serves to formalize the preceding petitions by connecting them to canonical biblical language.

[4]This title indicates the beginning of the second in a series of eight liturgical orders (sedarim) that comprise a major section of Ma'avar Yabok. Each order follows a similar structure with prayers and biblical verses organized by their sources, specifically designed to be recited for the sick or dying.

[5]These introductory verses serve as a standardized opening for each prayer sequence in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical system, creating ritual continuity throughout the book's prayer orders.

[i]The term 'שִׂיחֵנוּ' (sichenu) literally means 'our conversation' or 'our speech' but in this devotional context refers to prayer as an outpouring of one's heart, emphasizing the emotional and confessional nature of prayer.

[ii]This phrase deliberately echoes sacrificial language from the Torah (רֵיחַ נִיחֹחַ/'pleasing aroma') which described Temple offerings. In post-Temple Judaism, prayer was understood as a spiritual substitute for sacrifice, a theme that runs throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[iii]The Hebrew verb 'שַׁחֲרְנוּךָ' (shicharnucha) means 'we seek You early' or 'we seek You earnestly,' coming from a root meaning 'dawn' or 'early morning.' It implies both eagerness and the traditional Jewish emphasis on morning prayers.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 19:15 — The author ends this prayer with a well-known biblical verse that asks for divine acceptance of one's words and thoughts. This functions as a formal closing to the prayer sequence and connects the preceding petitions to established biblical language. | Cf. Song of Songs 8:13 — The prayer repurposes romantic language from Song of Songs into a plea for divine attention, transforming the human love relationship of the biblical text into a devotional relationship between the supplicant and God. | Cf. Leviticus 1:9 — The prayer likens verbal prayer to sacrificial offerings, a common theme in post-Temple Judaism where prayer became the substitute for physical Temple sacrifices. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theological framework of prayer as a spiritual substitute for Temple rituals. | Cf. Psalm 5:4 — The verb שַׁחֲרְנוּךָ (we seek You early) echoes the concept of morning prayer in Psalm 5, suggesting eagerness and prioritizing divine connection. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this may also metaphorically suggest seeking God early in the process of illness before it becomes critical.

[v]This phrase serves as a header indicating the beginning of the liturgical sequence for the second day (Monday) within the structured prayer system of Ma'avar Yabok.

[vi]"Ana Hashem" (Please, O Lord) refers to a specific set of introductory verses that begin each of the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok. These standardized opening verses were meant to be recited before the specific psalms for each day.

לעיל. אח״כ יתחיל מזמור יענך ה׳ ביום צרה תהלים סימן כ׳[i] תמצא לעיל[ii] אחר כך יאמר:

above. Afterward, he should begin Psalm 20,[1] “May the Lord answer you in the day of trouble,” which can be found above, and after that he should say:[2] 635R

(תורה) הַמַּלְאָךְ הַגֹּאֵל אֹתִי מִכָּל רָע[iii] יְבָרֵךְ אֶת הַנְּעָרִים וְיִקָּרֵא בָהֶם שְׁמִי וְשֵׁם אֲבֹתַי אַבְרָהָם וְיִצְחָק וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב[iv] בְּקֶרֶב הָאָרֶץ: מֵאֵל אָבִיךָ וְיַעְזְרֶךָּ[v] וְאֵת שַׁדַּי וִיבָרְכֶךָּ בִּרְכֹת שָׁמַיִם מֵעָל בִּרְכֹת תְּהוֹם רֹבֶצֶת תָּחַת[vi] בִּרְכֹת שָׁדַיִם וָרָחַם: בִּרְכֹת אָבִיךָ גָּבְרוּ עַל בִּרְכֹת הוֹרַי[vii] עַד תַּאֲוַת גִּבְעֹת עוֹלָם[viii] תִּהְיֶיךָ לְרֹאשׁ יוֹסֵף וּלְקָדְקֹד נְזִיר

“The angel who has redeemed me from all evil,[A] may he bless the lads,[3] and may my name be called upon them, and the name of my fathers Abraham and Isaac, and may they proliferate abundantly like fish in the midst of the earth.[B] From the God of your father who will help you, and with the Almighty who will bless you with blessings of heaven above, blessings of the deep that lies beneath,[C] blessings of the breasts and of the womb. The blessings of your father have prevailed over the blessings of my forebears, up to the utmost bounds of the everlasting 640R 645R

[A] Or: “The redeeming angel who has protected me from all harm” — This alternative translation emphasizes the protective role of the angel and uses ‘harm’ instead of ‘evil’ to better capture the broad range of dangers implied in the Hebrew word רָע, which includes misfortune and adversity beyond moral evil.

[B] Or: “and may they multiply like fishes throughout the land” — This more concise translation still captures the fish metaphor while being slightly more fluid in English, though it loses some of the emphatic quality of the original Hebrew phrase.

[C] Or: “blessings from the heavens above, blessings from the deep waters crouching below” — This translation preserves the more literal meaning of רֹבֶצֶת as ‘crouching’ or ‘lying in wait,’ capturing the ancient cosmological image of the waters beneath the earth as an active, potential force rather than a static entity.

[1] This psalm focuses on divine help in times of distress with verses like “Some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God” (verse 8). Its themes of divine protection during adversity make it particularly suitable for those who are ill.

[2] This is a transitional instruction that would have been followed by additional prayers or verses to be recited after Psalm 20, though they are not included in this excerpt.

[3] Jacob is referring to Joseph’s sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, whom he is adopting as his own in Genesis 48.

[i] Psalm 20 is particularly appropriate for the sick and suffering because it focuses on divine protection during times of trouble and adversity. It begins with “May the Lord answer you in the day of trouble” and contains themes of divine support and salvation.

[ii] The phrase “can be found above” indicates that the full text of Psalm 20 was previously included in the book, reflecting the practical reference nature of Ma’avar Yabok as a manual for those attending to the sick and dying.

[iii] This opening verse comes from Jacob’s blessing to Joseph’s sons in Genesis 48:16, where Jacob invokes the angel who protected him throughout his life to bless his grandchildren.

[iv] The Hebrew verb וְיִדְגּוּ (“may they proliferate”) derives from the word דָּג (fish), creating a metaphor of multiplying like fish, which are known for their abundant reproduction.

[v] This begins Jacob’s blessing to Joseph in Genesis 49:25-26, which is characterized by abundant imagery of fertility and prosperity.

[vi] “The deep that lies beneath” refers to underground waters as sources of blessing, complementing the “blessings of heaven above” (rain), creating a complete picture of divine abundance from all directions.

[vii] Jacob states that his blessings to Joseph exceed those he received from his own parents, suggesting an increasing flow of divine blessing through generations.

[viii] This poetic phrase literally means “to the desire/bounty of the eternal hills” and refers to the abundant produce of ancient, enduring mountains—symbolizing permanent, lasting blessings.

אֶחָיו׃ [i] חַכְלִילִי עֵינַיִם מִיָּיִן
וּלְבֶן שִׁנַּיִם מֵחָלָב׃ [ii] וַיִּסָּעוּ וַיְהִי
חִתַּת אֱלֹהִים [iii] עַל הֶעָרִים אֲשֶׁר
סְבִיבֹתֵיהֶם וְלֹא רָדְפוּ אַחֲרֵי
בְּנֵי יַעֲקֹב׃ לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי
יְיָ׃ [iv] וַיַּרְא אֱלֹהִים אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
וַיֵּדַע אֱלֹהִים׃ [v] וַיֹּאמֶר אֱלֹהִים אֶל
מֹשֶׁה אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה וַיֹּאמֶר כֹּה
תֹאמַר לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶהְיֶה שְׁלָחַנִי
אֲלֵיכֶם׃ [vi] [vii]

hills;[1] they shall be on the head of Joseph, and on the crown of the head of him who was separate from his brothers.[2] His eyes are darker than wine,[3] and his teeth whiter than milk. Then they journeyed, and the terror of God was upon the cities[4] that were around them, and they did not pursue the sons of Jacob. For Your salvation I hope, O LORD. And God saw the children of Israel, and God knew. And God said to Moses, "I AM WHO I AM."[A][5] And He said, "Thus you shall say to the children of Israel, 'I AM has sent me to you.'" 650R 655R

(נביאים) וְעַתָּה הוֹאֵל וּבָרֵךְ

(From the Prophets) And now, be pleased to bless

[A] Or: "I WILL BE WHAT I WILL BE" — The Hebrew verb אֶהְיֶה has future tense implications that this alternative better preserves, emphasizing God's ongoing actions and covenant faithfulness rather than just His self-existence.

[1] This poetic expression likely refers to the ancient, permanent hills of the Promised Land, symbolizing enduring, perpetual blessings that extend to the most distant horizons.
[2] The Hebrew term נָזִיר (nazir) here refers to Joseph's distinctive status, having been separated from his brothers when sold into Egypt, yet ultimately being elevated above them.
[3] This verse actually comes from Jacob's blessing to Judah (Genesis 49:12), not Joseph, showing how this collection combines different patriarchal blessings for spiritual effect.
[4] This refers to divine protection that prevented the Canaanites from attacking Jacob's family after the incident at Shechem, demonstrating God's protective power over His chosen people.
[5] This divine self-revelation (אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה) can also be translated as "I WILL BE WHAT I WILL BE," expressing God's eternal self-existence, independence, and covenant faithfulness to Israel.

[i] The term נָזִיר (nazir) here means "one who is separate" or "distinguished," referring to Joseph's elevated status among his brothers, rather than a Nazirite in the ritual sense.
[ii] This verse is from Jacob's blessing to Judah (Genesis 49:12), not Joseph, indicating that this collection of verses draws from different parts of Jacob's blessings to his sons.
[iii] This verse (Genesis 35:5) refers to the divine protection that Jacob and his family received after the incident at Shechem, showing God's protection over Jacob's descendants.
[iv] This brief verse from Genesis 49:18 appears in the middle of Jacob's blessings to his sons and represents a momentary pause where Jacob expresses his own reliance on divine salvation.
[v] This verse from Exodus 2:25 describes God's awareness of Israel's suffering in Egypt, indicating that God sees and knows the condition of His people even in their distress.
[vi] This concluding verse (Exodus 3:14) contains God's self-revelation to Moses at the burning bush, where the divine name אֶהְיֶה ("I AM" or "I WILL BE") expresses God's eternal presence and covenant faithfulness.
[vii] Cf. Genesis 48:16 — This passage appears at the beginning of this liturgical sequence because it establishes divine protection as the foundation for all subsequent blessings. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves to invoke spiritual protection for the sick or dying person. | Cf. Genesis 49:22-26 — The extensive blessing to Joseph is included here for its powerful imagery of comprehensive blessing 'from above' and 'from below,' making it appropriate for seeking complete healing and divine protection in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the sick. | Cf. Exodus 3:14 — The divine name אֶהְיֶה ("I AM") appears at the conclusion of this prayer sequence because it represents God's eternal presence and ability to act in all situations. In Ma'avar Yabok, this provides assurance of divine presence even in illness and at the approach of death. | Cf. Isaiah 6:3 — While not directly quoted, the sequencing of divine names and blessings in this passage evokes the atmosphere of Isaiah's throne vision, where God's presence is intensely manifest. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connects to instructions elsewhere in the text about reciting Isaiah's throne vision at the moment of death. | Cf. Genesis 35:5 — This verse is included to emphasize divine protection from external threats, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context would include both physical illness and spiritual dangers that might threaten the sick or dying person.

אֶת בֵּית עַבְדְּךָ לִהְיוֹת לְעוֹלָם
לְפָנֶיךָ[i] כִּי אַתָּה אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהִים
דִּבַּרְתָּ וּמִבִּרְכָתְךָ יְבֹרַךְ בֵּית
עַבְדְּךָ לְעוֹלָם: עַל כֵּן גָּדַלְתָּ יְיָ
אֱלֹהִים כִּי אֵין כָּמוֹךָ וְאֵין אֱלֹהִים
זוּלָתֶךָ בְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר שָׁמַעְנוּ בְאָזְנֵינוּ:
חֲזַק וְנִתְחַזֵּק בְּעַד עַמֵּנוּ[ii] וּבְעַד
עָרֵי אֱלֹהֵינוּ וַיהוָה יַעֲשֶׂה הַטּוֹב
בְּעֵינָיו: כִּי אַתָּה תָּאִיר נֵרִי
יְיָ אֱלֹהַי יַגִּיהַּ חָשְׁכִּי: יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי
אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק וְיִשְׂרָאֵל הַיּוֹם
יִוָּדַע כִּי אַתָּה אֱלֹהִים בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל
וְאָנִי עַבְדֶּךָ וּבִדְבָרְךָ יְיָ עָשִׂיתִי
אֶת כָּל הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה: עֲנֵנִי
יְיָ עֲנֵנִי וְיֵדְעוּ הָעָם הַזֶּה כִּי
אַתָּה אֱלֹהִים:[iii] וַיַּרְא כָּל הָעָם
וַיִּפְּלוּ עַל פְּנֵיהֶם וַיֹּאמְרוּ יְיָ הוּא
הָאֱלֹהִים יְיָ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים:[iv] יְהִי
יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ עִמָּנוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר הָיָה עִם
אֲבֹתֵינוּ אַל יַעַזְבֵנוּ וְאַל יִטְּשֵׁנוּ
לְהַטּוֹת לְבָבֵנוּ אֵלָיו לָלֶכֶת בְּכָל
דְּרָכָיו וְלִשְׁמֹר מִצְוֹתָיו וְחֻקָּיו

the house of Your servant, that it may continue forever before You; for You, O Lord God, have spoken, and from Your blessing may the house of Your servant be blessed forever.[1] Therefore You are great, O LORD God, for there is none like You, and there is no God besides You, according to all that we have heard with our ears. Be strong and let us strengthen ourselves for our people and for the cities of our God, and may the LORD do what is good in His eyes. For You will light my lamp; the LORD my God will enlighten my darkness.[2] O LORD, God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, let it be known this day that You are God in Israel, and that I am Your servant, and that by Your word, O LORD, I have done all these things.[3] Answer me, O LORD, answer me, that this people may know that You are God.[4] And all the people saw and fell on their faces, and they said, "The LORD, He is God! The LORD, He is God!"[5] May the LORD our God be with us, as He was with our fathers; may He not leave us nor forsake us, to incline our hearts to Him,[6] to walk in all His ways, and to keep His commandments and His

660R 665R 670R 675R 680R

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this prayer for perpetual blessing takes on added significance as a petition for the sick person's continued life and well-being.

[2] The metaphor of God illuminating darkness is particularly meaningful in the context of illness, which was often conceived in Jewish mystical tradition as a spiritual darkness requiring divine light for healing.

[3] This affirmation of divine authorization, originally spoken by Elijah before his miraculous demonstration of God's power, serves in this context to place the sick person's care under divine authority rather than merely human efforts.

[4] The repetition of "Answer me" (עֲנֵנִי) creates an intensified plea that would be recited with particular fervor at the sickbed. Kabbalistic tradition often associated such doubled expressions with the breaking through of divine barriers.

[5] This ecstatic declaration of God's sovereignty, recited twice for emphasis, appears in the Yom Kippur liturgy and represents the ultimate acceptance of divine judgment, making it particularly appropriate in contexts of life-threatening illness where one must accept divine will.

[6] This phrase is especially significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which emphasizes that proper spiritual preparation for death involves redirecting one's heart toward God in genuine interior transformation.

[i] This is from David's prayer in 2 Samuel 7:29, after Nathan delivered God's covenant promise to him. The original context is David requesting God's blessing on his royal dynasty, but in Ma'avar Yabok it is repurposed as a prayer for divine blessing during illness.

[ii] Originally from Joab's speech to his brother Abishai before battle with the Ammonites (2 Samuel 10:12), this phrase has been adapted from its military context to serve as spiritual encouragement during illness.

[iii] This verse from Elijah's confrontation with the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18:37) is particularly significant in Jewish tradition. The repetition "Answer me, answer me" is interpreted in the Talmud (Berakhot 9b) as requesting both that fire descend from heaven and that the people's minds be directed to recognize God's sovereignty.

[iv] This dramatic declaration from 1 Kings 18:39 is also recited at the conclusion of the Ne'ilah service on Yom Kippur, connecting this prayer to themes of divine judgment and ultimate redemption.

וּמִשְׁפָּטָיו אֲשֶׁר צִוָּה אֶת אֲבֹתֵינוּ:[i]

statutes and His judgments, which He commanded our fathers.

(תהלים) חִזְקוּ וְיַאֲמֵץ לְבַבְכֶם
כָּל הַמְיַחֲלִים לַיְיָ: וַאֲנִי עָלֶיךָ
בָּטָחְתִּי יְיָ אָמַרְתִּי אֱלֹהַי אָתָּה:
בְּיָדְךָ עִתֹּתָי הַצִּילֵנִי מִיַּד אוֹיְבַי
וּמֵרֹדְפָי: יְיָ הֵפִיר עֲצַת גּוֹיִם הֵנִיא
מַחְשְׁבוֹת עַמִּים: הִנֵּה עֵין יְיָ אֶל
יְרֵאָיו לַמְיַחֲלִים לְחַסְדּוֹ: לְהַצִּיל
מִמָּוֶת נַפְשָׁם וּלְחַיּוֹתָם בָּרָעָב:
נַפְשֵׁנוּ חִכְּתָה לַיְיָ עֶזְרֵנוּ וּמָגִנֵּנוּ
הוּא: כִּי בוֹ יִשְׂמַח לִבֵּנוּ כִּי בְשֵׁם
קָדְשׁוֹ בָּטָחְנוּ:[ii] יְהִי חַסְדְּךָ יְיָ
עָלֵינוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר יִחַלְנוּ לָךְ: זֶה עָנִי
קָרָא וַיהוָה שָׁמַע וּמִכָּל צָרוֹתָיו
הוֹשִׁיעוֹ: חֹנֶה מַלְאַךְ יְיָ סָבִיב
לִירֵאָיו[iii] וַיְחַלְּצֵם: טַעֲמוּ וּרְאוּ
כִּי טוֹב יְיָ אַשְׁרֵי הַגֶּבֶר יֶחֱסֶה בּוֹ:
כְּפִירִים רָשׁוּ וְרָעֵבוּ וְדֹרְשֵׁי יְיָ
לֹא יַחְסְרוּ כָל טוֹב: עִינֵי יְיָ אֶל
צַדִּיקִים וְאָזְנָיו אֶל שַׁוְעָתָם: צָעֲקוּ
וַיהוָה שָׁמַע וּמִכָּל צָרוֹתָם הִצִּילָם:

(Psalms) Be strong and let your heart take courage, all you who hope in the LORD. As for me, I have trusted in You, O LORD; I have said, "You are my God." My times are in Your hand; deliver me from the hand of my enemies and from my pursuers. The LORD frustrates the counsel of nations; He thwarts the plans of peoples. Behold, the eye of the LORD is upon those who fear Him, upon those who hope for His kindness, to save their souls from death and to sustain them in famine. Our soul waits for the LORD;[1] He is our help and our shield. For in Him our heart rejoices, for in His holy name we have trusted. May Your kindness, O LORD, be upon us, as we have hoped in You. This poor man called,[2] and the LORD heard, and from all his troubles He saved him. The angel of the LORD encamps around those who fear Him, and delivers them. Taste and see that the LORD is good; happy is the man who takes refuge in Him. Young lions suffer want and hunger, but those who seek the LORD shall not lack any

[1]The shift from third person ('their souls') to first person plural ('our soul') in this compilation reflects how these verses were adapted for communal recitation at a sickbed, where those present would recite them together with or on behalf of the ill person.

[2]This verse creates a narrative shift, moving from general principles about divine protection to a specific example of answered prayer. In the context of a sickbed prayer, this would encourage the ill person to identify with the 'poor man' whose prayer was heard.

[i]Cf. 2 Samuel 7:29 — This verse is from David's prayer after receiving God's covenant promise. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a powerful opening petition asking for God's blessing to continue perpetually, which is especially meaningful when praying for the sick. | Cf. 2 Samuel 7:22 — This continues David's prayer, affirming God's uniqueness and greatness. In the prayer for the sick, it establishes that the petitioner is turning to the only true source of healing and blessing. | Cf. 2 Samuel 10:12 — This verse from Joab's battle speech is repurposed in this prayer context to encourage strength and faith while acknowledging divine sovereignty over outcomes—particularly relevant when facing illness. | Cf. Psalm 18:28 — The light imagery in this psalm verse represents divine illumination during dark times, making it especially appropriate in prayers for those experiencing the darkness of illness. | Cf. 1 Kings 18:36 — This verse from Elijah's confrontation with the prophets of Baal emphasizes the speaker's identity as God's servant whose actions are divinely guided—in Ma'avar Yabok, this models proper relationship with God during illness. | Cf. 1 Kings 18:37-39 — These verses complete the reference to Elijah's dramatic demonstration of God's power, which in the context of prayers for the sick represents a petition for divine intervention that will manifest God's presence and power to all witnesses. | Cf. 1 Kings 8:57-58 — This verse from Solomon's prayer at the Temple dedication asks for God's continued presence and guidance. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a closing petition for divine assistance in maintaining faithfulness even during illness.

[ii]The emphasis on trust (בטחון) appears repeatedly throughout this passage, showing how Ma'avar Yabok presents trust in God as the proper spiritual response to illness and suffering.

[iii]This image of the angel of the LORD encamping around the faithful appears elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as part of the angelic protection formula that creates a spiritual shield around the ill person.

קָרוֹב יְיָ לְנִשְׁבְּרֵי לֵב[i] וְאֶת דַּכְּאֵי
רוּחַ יוֹשִׁיעַ: רַבּוֹת רָעוֹת צַדִּיק
וּמִכֻּלָּם יַצִּילֶנּוּ יְיָ: תִּמּוֹתַת רָשָׁע
רָעָה וְשֹׂנְאֵי צַדִּיק יֶאְשָׁמוּ: פּוֹדֶה
יְיָ נֶפֶשׁ עֲבָדָיו וְלֹא יֶאְשְׁמוּ כָּל
הַחֹסִים בּוֹ:[ii]

good. The eyes of the LORD are toward the righteous, and His ears are open to their cry. They cried out and the LORD heard, and from all their troubles He delivered them. The LORD is close to the brokenhearted, and saves those crushed in spirit. Many are the evils that befall the righteous one, but the LORD will deliver him from them all. Evil will slay the wicked, and the haters of the righteous will be held guilty. The LORD redeems the soul of His servants, and all who take refuge in Him will not be held guilty.[1] 705R 710R

לְדָוִד רִיבָה יְיָ אֶת יְרִיבַי[iii]
אֶת לֹחֲמָי: הַחֲזֵק מָגֵן וְצִנָּה[iv] וְקוּמָה
בְּעֶזְרָתִי: וְהָרֵק חֲנִית וּסְגֹר
לִקְרַאת רדְפָי אֱמֹר לְנַפְשִׁי יְשֻׁעָתֵךְ
אָנִי:[v] יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיִכָּלְמוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי
נַפְשִׁי יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיַחְפְּרוּ חֹשְׁבֵי

A Psalm of David:[2] Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me; fight against those who fight against me. Take hold of shield and buckler, and rise up to help me. Draw the spear and block the way against my pursuers; say to my soul, "I am your salvation."[3] May those who seek my life be 715R 720R

[1] The passage concludes with a powerful message of redemption and absolution, particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok where illness is often viewed as potentially atoning for sin. This ending offers reassurance that those who trust in God will ultimately be vindicated regardless of their current suffering.

[2] This introduction identifies the psalm as attributed to King David, though it is not explicitly stated in the Hebrew text presented here. The complete Psalm 35 is longer than the excerpt provided in Ma'avar Yabok's Tuesday prayer sequence.

[3] This direct divine statement to the soul is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which emphasizes the importance of divine reassurance for the soul during illness and at the moment of death.

[i] The concept that God is especially close to the brokenhearted provides spiritual comfort for the ill, suggesting that suffering can actually bring one closer to divine presence rather than indicating divine abandonment.

[ii] Cf. Psalms 34 — This passage is primarily composed of verses from Psalm 34, supplemented with verses from Psalms 31 and 33. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses have been carefully selected to create a prayer for the sick or dying that emphasizes divine protection, God's responsiveness to prayer, and trust in divine salvation. The compilation follows a common pattern in the text of creating therapeutic spiritual progressions from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation. | Cf. Psalms 31 — The inclusion of these specific verses from Psalm 31 is significant in a deathbed context because verse 6 from this same psalm ('Into Your hand I commit my spirit') is identified elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok as a central verse for deathbed recitation. The verses included here establish the theological foundation for that surrender—the recognition that one's times/destiny is in God's hands. | Cf. Psalms 33 — These verses emphasize divine providence and the futility of human plans against God's will, providing comfort to the sick or dying by placing their suffering within a larger divine framework. The theme of waiting for and trusting in divine deliverance is particularly relevant in contexts of illness or approaching death.

[iii] This is Psalm 35, a prayer for divine intervention against enemies. In Ma'avar Yabok, it appears in the prayer sequence for Tuesday (the second day), making it particularly appropriate for recitation during illness or times of distress.

[iv] The imagery of God taking up weapons to defend the psalmist is particularly potent in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where illness is often understood as an attack by negative spiritual forces that require divine intervention.

[v] The phrase "say to my soul, 'I am your salvation'" has special resonance in the context of deathbed prayers, as it directly addresses the soul's need for divine reassurance during its transition.

רָעָתִי:[i] וְנַפְשִׁי תָּגִיל בַּיהוָה תָּשִׂישׂ
בִּישׁוּעָתוֹ:[ii] כָּל עַצְמוֹתַי תֹּאמַרְנָה יְהוָה מִי כָמוֹךָ
מַצִּיל עָנִי מֵחָזָק מִמֶּנּוּ וְעָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן מִגֹּזְלוֹ:
יָקוּמוּן עֵדֵי חָמָס אֲשֶׁר לֹא יָדָעְתִּי יִשְׁאָלוּנִי:
יְשַׁלְּמוּנִי רָעָה תַּחַת טוּבָה שְׁכוֹל לְנַפְשִׁי:
וַאֲנִי בִּלְבוּשָׁם שָׂק עִנֵּיתִי בַצּוֹם נַפְשִׁי וּתְפִלָּתִי
עַל חֵיקִי תָּשׁוּב:[iii] כְּרֵעַ כְּאָח לִי הִתְהַלָּכְתִּי כְּאֵבֶל קוֹדֵר
שְׁחוֹתִי:[iv] וּבְצַלְעִי שָׂמְחוּ וְנֶאֱסָפוּ נֶאֱסָפוּ עָלַי נְכִים וְלֹא יָדָעְתִּי
קָרְעוּ וְלֹא דָמּוּ:[v] בַּחֲנֵפֵי לַעֲגֵי מָעוֹג חָרֹק עָלָי שִׁנָּיו:
אֲדֹנָי כַּמָּה תִרְאֶה הָשִׁיבָה נַפְשִׁי מִשֹּׁאֹתָם יְחִידָתִי
מִכְּפִירִים:[vi] אוֹדְךָ בְּקָהָל רָב בְּעַם עָצוּם אֲהַלְלֶךָּ:

put to shame and dishonored; may those who plot my harm be turned back and confounded. Then my soul shall rejoice in the LORD, exulting in His deliverance.[A] Awake and rouse Yourself for my judgment, my God and my Lord, for my cause. Let them be put to shame and confusion together, those who rejoice at my misfortune; let them be clothed with shame and dishonor, those who magnify themselves against me. Let those who desire my vindication shout for joy and be glad, and say evermore, "Great is the LORD, who delights in the well-being of His servant."[1] Then my tongue shall meditate on Your righteousness, all day long on Your praise.[B]

כִּי עִמְּךָ מְקוֹר חַיִּים בְּאוֹרְךָ נִרְאֶה
אוֹר:[v] גּוֹל עַל יְיָ דַּרְכֶּךָ וּבְטַח
עָלָיו וְהוּא יַעֲשֶׂה:[vi] וְהוֹצִיא
כָאוֹר צִדְקֶךָ וּמִשְׁפָּטְךָ כַּצָּהֳרָיִם:

For with You is the fountain of life; in Your light we see light. Commit your way to the LORD,[2] trust in Him, and He will act. He will bring forth your righteousness like the light, and your justice like

[A] Or: "And my soul shall exult in the LORD, rejoice in His salvation." — This alternative preserves the parallelism in the Hebrew more closely, with 'exult' corresponding to תָּגִיל and 'rejoice' to תָּשִׂישׂ. The Hebrew term יְשׁוּעָתוֹ is more directly rendered as 'salvation' rather than 'deliverance.'

[B] Or: "And my tongue shall murmur Your righteousness, all day long Your praise." — The Hebrew verb תֶּהְגֶּה (tehegeh) has connotations of a low, continuous utterance or murmuring that combines both speech and meditation. This alternative captures the sense of constant, quiet recitation that would be appropriate in a sickroom context.

[1] The phrase הֶחָפֵץ שְׁלוֹם עַבְדּוֹ literally means "who desires the peace/well-being of His servant," suggesting that God actively wants health and wholeness for the sufferer, an important theological point in the context of prayers for healing.

[2] The Hebrew uses the vivid verb "gol" (roll/commit), suggesting the complete transfer of one's burdens to God, like rolling a heavy stone away.

[i] In kabbalistic thought, as presented in Ma'avar Yabok, these "evil plotters" could be understood as both human enemies and negative spiritual forces (קליפות/kelipot) that gather around the ill person.

[ii] The transition from pleading to rejoicing in this verse reflects the therapeutic spiritual progression common in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences, which often move from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation.

[iii] The Hebrew term "shalom" encompasses not just peace but wholeness, well-being, and health, making this phrase particularly relevant in the context of prayers for healing.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's Tuesday prayer sequence — The psalm's themes of divine protection against enemies would be understood in the context of illness as a plea for God to fight against the spiritual forces causing suffering. The progression from distress to confidence mirrors the therapeutic spiritual journey that Ma'avar Yabok attempts to facilitate for the sick or dying person. | Cf. Psalm 91 (Shir Shel Pega'im) — The martial imagery in Psalm 35 (shields, spears, etc.) serves a similar protective function to Psalm 91, creating a spiritual shield around the ill person. Both psalms envision God actively intervening against forces that threaten the individual. | Cf. Confession (vidui) practices — The psalm's request for God to confound the 'accusers' parallels the function of confession (vidui) in Ma'avar Yabok, which is understood to neutralize spiritual prosecutors in the divine court.

[v] This is Psalm 36:10, a verse commonly used in Jewish liturgy that expresses the concept of God as the ultimate source of life and illumination.

[vi] This is from Psalm 37:5, where the unusual verb "גּוֹל" (commit/roll) suggests the complete transfer of one's burdens to God.

650 דּוֹם לַיְיָ וְהִתְחוֹלֵל לוֹ[i] אַל תִּתְחַר
בְּמַצְלִיחַ דַּרְכּוֹ בְּאִישׁ עֹשֶׂה מְזִמּוֹת:
אַתָּה סֵתֶר לִי מִצַּר תִּצְּרֵנִי רָנֵּי
פַלֵּט תְּסוֹבְבֵנִי סֶלָה:[ii] ישר הפוך
[iv iii]ישר:

the noonday. Be still before the LORD and wait patiently for Him;[A] do not fret over one who prospers in his way,[B] over the man who carries out 740R
evil devices. You are my hiding place; You preserve me from trouble; You surround me with songs of deliverance.[1] Selah. [Forward, reverse, forward][2]

655 (כתובים) רַבְתָּ אֲדֹנָי רִיבֵי נַפְשִׁי
גָּאַלְתָּ חַיָּי: רָאִיתָה יְיָ עַוָּתָתִי שָׁפְטָה
מִשְׁפָּטִי: כָּל נִקְמָתָם כָּל מַחְשְׁבֹתָם
לִי: שָׁמַעְתָּ חֶרְפָּתָם יְיָ כָּל מַחְשְׁבֹתָם
עָלַי שִׂפְתֵי קָמַי וְהֶגְיוֹנָם עָלַי כָּל
660 הַיּוֹם: שִׁבְתָּם וְקִימָתָם הַבִּיטָה
אֲנִי מַנְגִּינָתָם:[v] תֵּם עֲוֹנֵךְ בַּת
צִיּוֹן[vi] לֹא יוֹסִיף לְהַגְלוֹתֵךְ פָּקַד
עֲוֹנֵךְ בַּת אֱדוֹם גִּלָּה עַל חַטֹּאתָיִךְ:

(Writings) You, O Lord, have pleaded the causes of my soul;[3] You have redeemed my life. You have 745R
seen, O LORD, my oppression; judge my case. All their vengeance, all their schemes are against me. You have heard their reproach, O LORD, all their schemes against me, the lips of those who rise against me, and their meditation against me all day long. 750R
Look upon their sitting down and their rising up; I am their song. The punishment of your iniquity is

[A]Or: "Be silent before the LORD and travail for Him" — The Hebrew verb "וְהִתְחוֹלֵל" has connections to both waiting and childbirth/labor. This alternate translation emphasizes the active, painful aspect of spiritual waiting rather than the passive aspect, which might be more relevant in contexts of suffering or illness.

[B]Or: "do not compete with one who succeeds in his path" — The Hebrew "תִּתְחַר" can mean both "to fret/be angry" and "to compete/rival." This alternative emphasizes avoiding unhealthy comparison rather than emotional distress, which might be more applicable in contexts focusing on personal spiritual journey rather than emotional state.

[1]The imagery here is of being completely encircled by songs of salvation, creating a protective barrier of divine joy.

[2]This unusual notation (ישר הפוך ישר) appears to be a scribal or kabbalistic instruction suggesting these verses can be read in multiple directions for deeper mystical meaning, possibly relating to the practice of reading biblical texts in reverse for additional insights.

[3]The Hebrew phrase "רִיבֵי נַפְשִׁי" literally means "the contentions/disputes of my soul," suggesting legal advocacy. This verse from Lamentations 3:58 portrays God as an advocate who takes up the case of the suffering person.

[i]From Psalm 37:7, where "וְהִתְחוֹלֵל" can mean both "wait patiently" and "be brought forth in birth pangs," suggesting that waiting for divine intervention can be both passive and intensely active.

[ii]From Psalm 32:7, describing God as a protective sanctuary surrounded by songs of deliverance.

[iii]This is a scribal or kabbalistic notation meaning "forward, reverse, forward," likely indicating a reading instruction for the preceding verses, suggesting they can be read in multiple directions for additional mystical meaning.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 36:10 — This verse establishes the theological foundation that God is the ultimate source of both life and illumination, a key concept in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as transition rather than termination. | Cf. Psalm 37:5-7 — These verses from Psalm 37 provide guidance for the sick person to fully surrender their situation to God and wait patiently for divine intervention, aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on acceptance of divine judgment. | Cf. Psalm 32:7 — This verse offers reassurance of divine protection and deliverance, particularly relevant for someone facing illness or approaching death, reinforcing the book's message that proper spiritual preparation creates divine protection.

[v]The phrase "I am their song" (אֲנִי מַנְגִּינָתָם) appears in Lamentations 3:63, where it refers to the mockery endured by the suffering person. In this context, it indicates how the enemies make the speaker an object of derision and contempt.

[vi]This verse from Lamentations 4:22 marks a significant shift from the personal lament to a prophetic pronouncement of comfort directed at Jerusalem (daughter of Zion).

זְכֹר יְיָ מָה הָיָה לָּנוּ הַבִּיטָה וּרְאֵה
665 אֶת חֶרְפָּתֵנוּ: [i] נַחֲלָתֵנוּ נֶהֶפְכָה
לְזָרִים בָּתֵּינוּ לְנָכְרִים: יָתוֹם
הָיִינוּ אֵין אָב אִמֹּתֵינוּ כְּאַלְמָנוֹת:
מֵימֵינוּ בַכֶּסֶף שָׁתִינוּ בְּמָחִיר
עֵצֵינוּ עַל צַוָּארֵנוּ נִרְדָּפְנוּ יָגַעְנוּ
וְלֹא הוּנַח לָנוּ: מִצְרַיִם נָתַנּוּ יָד
אַשּׁוּר לְשָׂבַע לָחֶם: אֲבוֹתֵינוּ חָטְאוּ
וְאֵינָם אֲנַחְנוּ סָבַלְנוּ עֲוֹנֹתָם:
עֲבָדִים מָשְׁלוּ בָּנוּ פֹּרֵק אֵין
מִיָּדָם: בְּנַפְשֵׁנוּ נָבִיא לַחְמֵנוּ
מִפְּנֵי חֶרֶב הַמִּדְבָּר: עוֹרֵנוּ כְּתַנּוּר
נִכְמָרוּ מִפְּנֵי זַלְעֲפוֹת רָעָב:
נָשִׁים בְּצִיּוֹן עִנּוּ בְּתוּלוֹת בְּעָרֵי
יְהוּדָה: שָׂרִים בְּיָדָם נִתְלוּ פְּנֵי
זְקֵנִים לֹא נֶהְדָּרוּ: בַּחוּרִים טַחֲנָה
וּנְעָרִים בָּעֵצִי כָשָׁלוּ: זְקֵנִים
מִשַּׁעַר בָּחוּרִים מִנְגִּינָתָם:
שָׁבַת מְשׂוֹשׂ לִבֵּנוּ נֶהְפַּךְ מִסְפְּדֵנוּ
לְמָחוֹל: נָפְלָה עֲטֶרֶת רֹאשֵׁנוּ אוֹי
נָא לָנוּ כִּי חָטָאנוּ: עַל זֶה הָיָה דָוֶה
לִבֵּנוּ עַל אֵלֶּה חָשְׁכוּ עֵינֵינוּ:
עַל הַר צִיּוֹן שָׁמֵם שׁוּעָלִים הָלְכוּ בוֹ:
אַתָּה יְיָ לְעוֹלָם תֵּשֵׁב כִּסְאֲךָ לְדֹר
וָדֹר: לָמָּה לָנֶצַח תִּשְׁכָּחֵנוּ תַּעַזְבֵנוּ לְאֹרֶךְ
יָמִים: הֲשִׁיבֵנוּ יְיָ אֵלֶיךָ וְנָשׁוּבָה
חַדֵּשׁ יָמֵינוּ כְּקֶדֶם: [ii] כִּי אִם מָאֹס מְאַסְתָּנוּ
קָצַפְתָּ עָלֵינוּ עַד מְאֹד: [iii] כִּי יֵשׁ עֵת לְכָל
חֵפֶץ וְעֵת לְכָל מַעֲשֶׂה: כִּי אֵין דָּבָר
אֲשֶׁר שָׁם שִׁלְטוֹן מֶלֶךְ וּמִי יֹאמַר לוֹ מַה
תַּעֲשֶׂה: לֵךְ אֱכֹל בְּשִׂמְחָה לַחְמֶךָ
וּשְׁתֵה בְלֵב טוֹב יֵינֶךָ כִּי כְבָר רָצָה
הָאֱלֹהִים אֶת מַעֲשֶׂיךָ: [iv] וּמָרְדֳּכַי
יָצָא מִלִּפְנֵי הַמֶּלֶךְ [v] בִּלְבוּשׁ
מַלְכוּת תְּכֵלֶת וְחוּר וַעֲטָרַת זָהָב
גְּדוֹלָה וְתַכְרִיךְ בּוּץ וְאַרְגָּמָן
וְהָעִיר שׁוּשָׁן צָהֲלָה וְשָׂמֵחָה:
לַיְּהוּדִים הָיְתָה אוֹרָה וְשִׂמְחָה
וְשָׂשׂוֹן וִיקָר: [vi] [vii]

complete, O daughter of Zion;[A] He will no longer send you into exile. He has punished your iniquity, O daughter of Edom; He has uncovered your sins. Remember, O LORD, what has happened to us; look and see our disgrace. Our inheritance has been turned over to strangers, our houses to foreigners. Why do You forget us forever and forsake us for so long?[1] Return us to You, O LORD, and we shall return; renew our days as of old. For where the king's word is, there is power;[2] and who may say to him, "What are you doing?"[B] Go, eat your bread with joy,[C] and drink your wine with a glad heart; for God has already approved your works.[3] And Mordechai went out from the presence of the king in royal apparel of blue and white, with a great crown of gold and a garment of fine linen and purple; and the city

[A] Or: "Your iniquity has ended, O daughter of Zion" — The Hebrew "תֹּם" primarily means "finished/completed/ended" rather than specifically "punishment." This alternate translation emphasizes the completion or ending of the sinful state itself rather than focusing on the punitive aspect.

[B] Or: "and who can question what he does?" — This more idiomatic translation better captures the rhetorical force of the question, emphasizing that no one has the right or authority to challenge the king's (or God's) decisions.

[C] Or: "Go, enjoy your food with gladness" — This translation broadens "bread" to "food" and varies the word for joy, which might make the meaning more accessible to modern readers while preserving the essential meaning.

[1] This question from Lamentations 5:20 expresses the tension between faith in God's ultimate redemption and the experience of prolonged suffering, a sentiment that would resonate deeply with the sick or dying.

[2] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse from Ecclesiastes takes on additional meaning beyond its original context. Here it likely suggests that just as a human king's word carries absolute authority, how much more so does God's decree, encouraging acceptance of divine judgment.

[3] This comforting statement from Ecclesiastes suggests that despite current suffering, God has already found favor with the person's life and deeds, offering spiritual reassurance to the ill or dying.

[i] These verses from Lamentations 5:1-2 shift to a communal lament, moving from the individual "I" of earlier verses to the collective "our" suffering.

[ii] This verse from Lamentations 5:21 represents the culminating plea of the book of Lamentations, expressing hope for restoration through divine intervention.

[iii] The passage shifts here from Lamentations to Ecclesiastes 8:4, creating a transition from lament to wisdom literature that emphasizes divine sovereignty.

[iv] This verse from Ecclesiastes 9:7 offers consolation by suggesting that God already accepts the sufferer's deeds, encouraging enjoyment of simple pleasures even in difficult times.

[v] The passage makes another abrupt transition here to Esther 8:15, shifting from wisdom literature to narrative, depicting Mordechai's triumph and elevation after near destruction.

[vi] This concluding verse from Esther 8:16 represents the complete reversal of fortune for the Jewish people, from mourning to celebration, mirroring the hoped-for transformation of the sick or dying person's condition.

[vii] Cf. Lamentations 3:58-63 — In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses would help the sick or dying person express their suffering while maintaining faith that God ultimately defends them against both physical ailments and spiritual accusers. | Cf. Lamentations 4:22 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse would suggest that the suffering person's spiritual purification is complete, while divine judgment will fall upon their spiritual enemies. | Cf. Lamentations 5:1-2, 20-21 — In Ma'avar

of Shushan rejoiced and was glad. For the Jews there was light and gladness, joy and honor.[1] 770R

עוֹנֶה מִמְצַר קוֹרְאָיו[i] וּלְתַאֲלָתָם רְפוּאָה מְמַהֵר לִשְׁלוֹחַ. פּוֹנֶה לַעֲנוֹת עָנְיֵי תְּפִלָּתוֹ בַּל לִשְׁקֹץ[ii] וְלֵאלוֹהַּ צָעוֹק נִצְעָק מִכְּאֵב לֵב וְנִסְגּוֹד וְנִפְלוֹחַ:[iii] אֵל אֱלֹהֵינוּ כִּי יַרְבֶּה לִסְלוֹחַ:[iv]

He answers those who call Him from distress, and to their supplication He swiftly sends healing.[2] He turns to respond to the poor, never rejecting their prayer,[3] and to God we shall cry out from the pain of our heart, and we shall bow down and serve Him, for our God abundantly forgives.[4] 775R

למנחה ליום שני

For the Afternoon Prayer of Monday

מתחיל מזמור לדוד ה׳ רועי סי׳ כ״ג[v] תמצא לעיל[vi]

Begin Psalm 23,[5] “The LORD is my shepherd” (Psalm 23), you will find it above.[6]

[1]The passage concludes with this verse from Esther describing the Jews’ salvation from destruction, symbolically representing the hope for spiritual redemption even when physical healing may not occur.

[2]The Hebrew ‘לתאלתם’ (to their supplication/request) is connected to the root אלה, suggesting an earnest or even desperate appeal, conveying the urgency of prayers offered during serious illness.

[3]The prayer emphasizes that God’s receptiveness to prayer is universal and without discrimination, with special attention to the prayers of the poor and suffering—a particularly relevant assurance in the context of sickbed prayers.

[4]This closing quote from Isaiah 55:7 transforms what began as a prayer for physical healing into a more comprehensive appeal for spiritual restoration, suggesting the interconnection between physical and spiritual wellbeing central to Ma’avar Yabok’s approach.

[5]This is a navigational instruction in the prayer manual, not the text of the psalm itself. The author is directing the reader to recite Psalm 23 at this point in the liturgical sequence but is not reprinting the text since it appears elsewhere in the book.

[6]This instruction demonstrates how Ma’avar Yabok functions as a practical manual with cross-

Yabok, these verses would help connect the individual’s suffering to the broader community’s historical experience while expressing hope for restoration, whether through healing or through a blessed afterlife. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 8:4 — In Ma’avar Yabok, this verse would encourage acceptance of divine sovereignty and judgment, helping the sick person submit to God’s will regarding their condition. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 9:7 — In Ma’avar Yabok, this would provide spiritual comfort to the sick person by suggesting that God has already accepted their life and deeds, regardless of their current suffering. | Cf. Esther 8:15-16 — In Ma’avar Yabok, these verses offer a powerful metaphor of transformation from mourning to joy, suggesting that suffering can be followed by redemption, either through physical healing or spiritual elevation after death.

[i]There is a wordplay here on ‘מצר’ (distress/strait) which evokes both the physical narrowness of constriction and the emotional experience of distress. The phrase echoes Psalm 118:5.

[ii]The Hebrew uses a negative construction with ‘bal’ (not) and ‘shakeitz’ (reject/abhor), emphasizing that God never finds prayer repulsive, regardless of who offers it.

[iii]These Aramaic-influenced terms for worship (‘nisgod’—we shall bow down, and ‘nifloch’—we shall serve) create a solemn, formal tone, emphasizing total devotion in response to divine mercy.

[iv]Cf. Psalms 118:5 — This prayer draws on the psalmist’s experience of calling to God in distress and receiving an answer, connecting the individual experience to the communal prayer context. | Cf. Isaiah 57:15 — The prayer affirms God’s special attention to the prayers of the poor and distressed, a recurring theme in prophetic literature that emphasized God’s care for the vulnerable. | Cf. Isaiah 55:7 — Concluding with this direct quote from Isaiah emphasizes divine forgiveness as the ultimate response to human distress and prayer, suggesting that many of the ailments being prayed about may be understood as connected to sin requiring forgiveness.

[v]This is a navigational instruction directing the reader to find Psalm 23 (“The LORD is my shepherd”) in an earlier part of the text. The abbreviation ׳סי (siman) means “section” or “number.”

[vi]This phrase means “you will find it above,” indicating that Psalm 23 has already appeared earlier in the text and should be referenced from there rather than being repeated here.

(תורה) יְיָ יִלָּחֶם לָכֶם וְאַתֶּם
690 תַּחֲרִישׁוּן׃[i] עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ וַיְהִי לִי
לִישׁוּעָה׃[ii] זֶה אֵלִי וְאַנְוֵהוּ אֱלֹהֵי
אָבִי וַאֲרֹמְמֶנְהוּ׃ יְיָ אִישׁ מִלְחָמָה יְיָ
שְׁמוֹ׃ יְמִינְךָ יְיָ נֶאְדָּרִי בַכֹּחַ יְמִינְךָ
יְיָ תִּרְעַץ אוֹיֵב׃ מִי כָמֹכָה בָּאֵלִם
695 יְיָ[iii] מִי כָּמֹכָה נֶאְדָּר בַּקֹּדֶשׁ נוֹרָא
תְהִלֹּת עֹשֵׂה פֶלֶא׃ תִּפֹּל עֲלֵיהֶם
אֵימָתָה וָפַחַד בִּגְדֹל זְרוֹעֲךָ יִדְמוּ
כָּאָבֶן׃ עַד יַעֲבֹר עַמְּךָ יְיָ עַד יַעֲבֹר
עַם זוּ קָנִיתָ׃[iv] לָכֵן אֱמֹר לִבְנֵי
700 יִשְׂרָאֵל אֲנִי יְיָ וְהוֹצֵאתִי אֶתְכֶם
מִתַּחַת סִבְלֹת מִצְרַיִם וְהִצַּלְתִּי
אֶתְכֶם מֵעֲבֹדָתָם וְגָאַלְתִּי אֶתְכֶם
בִּזְרוֹעַ נְטוּיָה וּבִשְׁפָטִים גְּדֹלִים׃
לֵךְ שֻׁב מִצְרַיִם כִּי מֵתוּ כָּל הָאֲנָשִׁים
705 [vi] [v] הַמְבַקְשִׁים אֶת נַפְשֶׁךָ׃

(Torah) The LORD will fight for you, and you shall 780R
be silent.[A] The LORD is my strength and song, and
He has become my salvation. This is my God, and
I will glorify Him; my father's God, and I will exalt
Him. The LORD is a man of war; the LORD is His
name. Your right hand, O LORD, glorious in power, 785R
Your right hand, O LORD, shatters the enemy. Who
is like You among the mighty, O LORD? Who is like
You, glorious in holiness, awesome in praises, doing
wonders? Terror and dread fall upon them; by the
greatness of Your arm they are still as stone;[B] until 790R
Your people pass over, O LORD, until the people
whom You have purchased pass over.[1] Therefore say
to the children of Israel: I am the LORD, and I will
bring you out from under the burdens of the Egyp-
tians, and I will deliver you from their bondage, and I 795R
will redeem you with an outstretched arm and with
great judgments. Go, return to Egypt, for all the

[A] Or: "The LORD will battle for you, while you remain still" — This alternate translation emphasizes the physical stillness aspect of 'tacharishun' rather than vocal silence, which might be more appropriate in the context of a deathbed where the person may be physically unable to move.

[B] Or: "by the greatness of Your arm they are silenced like stone" — The verb 'yidmu' shares roots with both silence and stillness. This alternate captures the sense of enemies being rendered speechless with awe, which adds a dimension of divine power over accusers that might be relevant in the context of death prayers.

references to avoid unnecessary repetition of biblical texts. Since Psalm 23 is a well-known text that appears multiple times in the prayer sequences, the author simply directs readers to the previous occurrence.

[1] The Hebrew 'ya'avor' (pass over) creates a direct connection to the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok). In the context of prayers for the dying, this suggests that just as God protected Israel during their crossing of the Red Sea, He will protect the soul during its transition.

[i] This verse (Exodus 14:14) comes from Moses' words to the Israelites at the Red Sea as the Egyptian army pursued them, emphasizing divine intervention in the face of mortal danger.

[ii] This begins the Song of the Sea (Exodus 15:2), sung by Moses and the Israelites after crossing the Red Sea. This collection of verses focuses on God's power to protect Israel and redeem them from Egyptian bondage.

[iii] This iconic verse (Exodus 15:11) is incorporated into the daily liturgy in the Amidah prayer and features prominently in the Passover Haggadah.

[iv] The Hebrew word 'ya'avor' (pass over) relates to the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok), creating a thematic connection between Israel's crossing of the Red Sea and the soul's transition after death.

[v] This verse (Exodus 4:19) describes God's command to Moses to return to Egypt after his exile in Midian. In the context of prayers for the sick, this verse may represent hope that dangers to the soul have passed.

[vi] Cf. Song of the Sea (Exodus 15) — These verses from the Song of the Sea emphasize God's power to protect and deliver, particularly in moments of transition. In Ma'avar Yabok, they serve as a spiritual parallel between the Israelites' crossing of the Red Sea and the soul's crossing to the afterlife. | Cf. Four expressions of redemption — These expressions of redemption ('I will bring you out,' 'I will deliver you,' 'I will redeem you') may be intended to remind the sick or dying person of God's power to deliver from all forms of bondage, including physical suffering.

men who sought your life are dead.[1]

(נביאים) כִּי רָאָה יְיָ אֶת עֳנִי
יִשְׂרָאֵל מֹרֶה מְאֹד[i] וְאֶפֶס עָצוּר
וְאֶפֶס עָזוּב[ii] וְאֵין עֹזֵר לְיִשְׂרָאֵל:
וְעַתָּה יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ הוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ נָא
מִיָּדוֹ וְיֵדְעוּ כָּל מַמְלְכוֹת הָאָרֶץ
כִּי אַתָּה יְיָ אֱלֹהִים לְבַדֶּךָ:
אוֹדְךָ יְיָ כִּי אָנַפְתָּ בִּי יָשֹׁב אַפְּךָ
וּתְנַחֲמֵנִי:[iii] הִנֵּה אֵל יְשׁוּעָתִי
אֶבְטַח וְלֹא אֶפְחָד: כִּי עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת
יָהּ[iv] יְיָ וַיְהִי לִי לִישׁוּעָה: יְיָ חָנֵנוּ
לְךָ קִוִּינוּ הֱיֵה זְרֹעָם לַבְּקָרִים[v] אַף
יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ בְּעֵת צָרָה: כִּי יְיָ שֹׁפְטֵנוּ
יְיָ מְחֹקְקֵנוּ יְיָ מַלְכֵּנוּ הוּא יוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ:
חָזְקוּ יָדִים רָפוֹת וּבִרְכַּיִם כֹּשְׁלוֹת
אִמְצוּ.[vi] יְיָ לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי וּנְגִנוֹתַי

(From the Prophets) For the LORD saw the affliction of Israel, which was very bitter,[2] and there was no one confined and no one abandoned,[A] and no helper for Israel. And now, O LORD our God, save us, we pray, from his hand, and let all the kingdoms of the earth know that You alone, O LORD, are God. I will thank You, O LORD, for though You were angry with me, Your anger has turned away, and You comfort me.[3] Behold, God is my salvation; I will trust and not be afraid. For the LORD God is my strength and my song,[B] and He has become my salvation. O LORD, be gracious to us; we have waited for You. Be their arm every morning, our salvation also in time of trouble. For the LORD is our judge, the LORD is our lawgiver, the LORD is our king; He

[A] Or: "and there was neither bond nor free" — This alternate translation uses more idiomatic English to convey the Hebrew merism that suggests the totality of absence of support across all social classes. However, it loses some of the literal meaning of the original terms.

[B] Or: "For my strength and protection is Yah, the LORD" — The Hebrew word "zimrat" has been debated by scholars, with some suggesting it refers to "protection" or "might" rather than "song." This alternate translation reflects that scholarly perspective but is less traditional.

[1] This concluding verse may function metaphorically in this prayer sequence to suggest that spiritual accusers or dangers to the soul have been neutralized, offering reassurance to the dying person.

[2] This opening verse sets a tone of divine compassion, establishing that God sees and responds to suffering. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse suggests that God likewise sees the suffering of the sick person for whom these prayers are being recited.

[3] This verse reflects the theological framework of Ma'avar Yabok that suffering can be understood as divine correction rather than punishment. Just as God's anger turns to comfort, so illness can lead to healing and spiritual renewal.

[i] The word "moreh" (מֹרֶה) comes from the root meaning "bitter" or "rebellious." In this context, it describes the severity of Israel's affliction, which was exceedingly bitter or grievous. The entire phrase echoes 2 Kings 14:26.

[ii] This poetic pair refers to the complete absence of support for Israel—no one confined (possibly referring to those in fortresses) and no one left free who could help. It emphasizes total abandonment and helplessness.

[iii] The verbs shift here from perfect to imperfect tense, expressing both completed action (God's anger has turned) and ongoing action (the comfort continues). This reflects the prayer's theological understanding that divine healing follows divine chastisement.

[iv] This phrase draws directly from the Song at the Sea (Exodus 15:2), connecting the present need for healing with Israel's paradigmatic salvation from Egypt. The word "zimrat" means "song" but also carries connotations of "strength," creating a powerful wordplay.

[v] The phrase "be their arm every morning" uses the image of God's arm (a symbol of divine power) as a continual source of strength. "Morning" in biblical imagery often represents a time of divine mercy and renewal after the "night" of suffering.

[vi] This verse from Isaiah 35:3 serves both as a prayer for physical healing (strengthening weak limbs) and as spiritual encouragement. In its original context, it was part of Isaiah's vision of future restoration where the blind would see, the deaf would hear, and the lame would leap like deer.

נְנַגֵּן כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּינוּ עַל בֵּית יְיָ׃[i][ii]

will save us. Strengthen the weak hands, and make firm the feeble knees. O LORD, save me, and we will play my music all the days of our lives at the house of the LORD.[A] 815R

(תהלים) וְעוֹד מְעַט וְאֵין רָשָׁע
וְהִתְבּוֹנַנְתָּ עַל מְקוֹמוֹ וְאֵינֶנּוּ׃
חֶרֶב פָּתְחוּ רְשָׁעִים וְדָרְכוּ קַשְׁתָּם
לְהַפִּיל עָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן לִטְבוֹחַ
יִשְׁרֵי דָרֶךְ׃ חַרְבָּם תָּבוֹא בְלִבָּם
וְקַשְׁתוֹתָם תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה׃ כִּי זְרוֹעוֹת
רְשָׁעִים תִּשָּׁבַרְנָה וְסוֹמֵךְ צַדִּיקִים
יְיָ׃ לֹא יֵבֹשׁוּ בְּעֵת רָעָה וּבִימֵי
רְעָבוֹן יִשְׂבָּעוּ׃ כִּי יִפֹּל לֹא יוּטָל
כִּי יְיָ סוֹמֵךְ יָדוֹ׃[iii] קַוֵּה אֶל יְיָ
וּשְׁמֹר דַּרְכּוֹ וִירוֹמֶמְךָ לָרֶשֶׁת
אָרֶץ בְּהִכָּרֵת רְשָׁעִים תִּרְאֶה׃
רָאִיתִי רָשָׁע עָרִיץ וּמִתְעָרֶה
כְּאֶזְרָח רַעֲנָן׃[iv] וַיַּעֲבֹר וְהִנֵּה
אֵינֶנּוּ וָאֲבַקְשֵׁהוּ וְלֹא נִמְצָא׃
וּתְשׁוּעַת צַדִּיקִים מֵיְיָ מָעוּזָּם בְּעֵת
צָרָה׃ וַיַּעְזְרֵם יְיָ וַיְפַלְּטֵם
מֵרְשָׁעִים וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם כִּי חָסוּ בוֹ׃
אֲדֹנָי נָגִדְךָ כָל תַּאֲוָתִי וְאַנְחָתִי
מִמְּךָ לֹא נִסְתָּרָה׃ יְיָ אַל בְּקֶצְפְּךָ
תוֹכִיחֵנִי וּבַחֲמָתְךָ תְיַסְּרֵנִי׃ כִּי

(Psalms) Yet a little while, and the wicked will be no more; you will look at his place, and he will not be there. The wicked draw the sword and bend their bow to bring down the poor and needy, to slaughter those whose way is upright. Their swords shall enter their own hearts, and their bows shall be broken. For the arms of the wicked shall be broken, but the LORD supports the righteous. The righteous shall not be ashamed in the time of evil, and in the days of famine they shall be satisfied. For if he falls, he shall not be cast down, because the LORD supports his hand. Wait for the LORD and keep His way, and He will exalt you to inherit the land; when the wicked are cut off, you shall see it. I have seen a wicked, violent man spreading himself like a flourishing native tree. But he passed away, and behold, he was no more; I sought him, but he could not be found. The salvation of the righteous is from the LORD, He is their stronghold in time of trouble. The LORD helps them and delivers them; He delivers them from the wicked and saves them, because they take refuge in 820R 825R 830R 835R

[A] Or: "and we will play my stringed instruments all the days of our lives in the house of the LORD" — The Hebrew "neginot" specifically refers to stringed instruments. This more precise translation clarifies the type of music but is slightly less flowing in English.

[i] This concluding verse comes from Hezekiah's song of thanksgiving after his recovery from a fatal illness (Isaiah 38:20), making it particularly appropriate in a prayer for healing. It expresses the commitment to lifelong gratitude and worship following divine salvation.

[ii] Cf. 2 Kings 14:26 — This verse is used to establish Israel's desperate condition requiring divine intervention, setting the context for the subsequent prayers for salvation | Cf. Isaiah 12:1-2 — These verses function as an expression of confidence that God's anger will turn to comfort, providing reassurance to the sick person that divine healing follows divine chastisement | Cf. Exodus 15:2 — The reference to the Song at the Sea connects the present need for healing with Israel's paradigmatic salvation from Egypt, suggesting that God's saving power is constant throughout history | Cf. Isaiah 33:2, 22 — By combining these verses, the prayer emphasizes God's roles as both merciful savior and righteous judge, suggesting that salvation comes through divine governance | Cf. Isaiah 35:3 — This verse serves both as a prayer for physical healing (strengthening weak limbs) and as spiritual encouragement for the sick person to maintain faith during illness | Cf. Isaiah 38:20 — This reference is particularly apt for the sick, as it comes from King Hezekiah's thanksgiving after being healed from a fatal illness, suggesting that the current suffering will likewise lead to restoration and thanksgiving

[iii] This verse about God supporting the hand of the fallen righteous person is especially relevant in the context of illness, where the sick person may feel physically and spiritually fallen. The image of God's hand supporting one's own offers powerful reassurance.

[iv] The phrase "like a flourishing native tree" is a powerful image of temporary prosperity that will ultimately pass away. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this metaphor would be particularly meaningful for the sick person, emphasizing that even the most apparently robust wicked person eventually disappears, while the righteous receive divine support.

לְךָ יְיָ הוֹחַלְתִּי אַתָּה תַּעֲנֶה אֲדֹנָי
אֱלֹהָי: אַל תַּעְזְבֵנִי יְהוָה אֱלֹהָי
אַל תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי: חוּשָׁה לְעֶזְרָתִי
יְיָ תְּשׁוּעָתִי: וְעַתָּה מַה קִּוִּיתִי אֲדֹנָי
תּוֹחַלְתִּי לְךָ הִיא: מִכָּל פְּשָׁעַי
הַצִּילֵנִי חֶרְפַּת נָבָל אַל תְּשִׂימֵנִי:
שָׁמְעָה תְפִלָּתִי יְיָ וְשַׁוְּעָתִי הַאֲזִינָה
אֶל דִּמְעָתִי אַל תֶּחֱרַשׁ כִּי גֵר אָנֹכִי
עִמָּךְ תוֹשָׁב כְּכָל אֲבוֹתָי:[i] קְוֹה
קִוִּיתִי יְיָ וַיֵּט אֵלַי וַיִּשְׁמַע שַׁוְּעָתִי:
אַתָּה יְיָ לֹא תִכְלָא רַחֲמֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי
חַסְדְּךָ וַאֲמִתְּךָ תָּמִיד יִצְּרוּנִי: רְצֵה
יְיָ לְהַצִּילֵנִי יְיָ לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה:
יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ יַחַד מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי
לִסְפּוֹתָהּ יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיִכָּלְמוּ
חֲפֵצֵי רָעָתִי: יָשֻׁמּוּ עַל עֵקֶב בָּשְׁתָּם
הָאֹמְרִים לִי הֶאָח הֶאָח: וַאֲנִי עָנִי
וְאֶבְיוֹן[ii] אֲדֹנָי יַחֲשָׁב לִי עֶזְרָתִי
וּמְפַלְטִי אַתָּה אֱלֹהַי אַל תְּאַחַר:
אֲנִי אָמַרְתִּי יְיָ חָנֵּנִי רְפָאָה נַפְשִׁי
כִּי חָטָאתִי לָךְ:[iii] בְּוֹאת יָדַעְתִּי כִּי
חָפַצְתָּ בִּי כִּי לֹא יָרִיעַ אוֹיְבִי עָלָי:
וְאַתָּה יְיָ חָנֵּנִי וַהֲקִימֵנִי וַאֲשַׁלְּמָה
לָהֶם: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
מֵהָעוֹלָם וְעַד הָעוֹלָם אָמֵן וְאָמֵן:
כְּאַיָּל תַּעֲרֹג עַל אֲפִיקֵי מָיִם[iv] כֵּן
נַפְשִׁי תַעֲרֹג אֵלֶיךָ אֱלֹהִים: מַה
תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי[v] נַפְשִׁי וַתֶּהֱמִי עָלָי
הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים כִּי עוֹד אוֹדֶנּוּ
יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנָיו: שָׁפְטֵנִי אֱלֹהִים

Him. O Lord, all my desire is before You,[1] and my
sighing is not hidden from You. O LORD, do not 840R
rebuke me in Your anger, nor chastise me in Your
wrath. For in You, O LORD, do I hope; You will an-
swer, O Lord my God. Do not forsake me, O LORD
my God; do not be far from me. Hasten to help me,
O LORD, my salvation. And now, what do I wait 845R
for, O Lord? My hope is in You. Deliver me from all
my transgressions; do not make me the scorn of the
fool. Hear my prayer, O LORD, and give ear to my
cry; do not be silent at my tears, for I am a stranger
with You, a sojourner like all my fathers. Earnestly 850R
I waited for the LORD, and He inclined to me and
heard my cry. You, O LORD, will not withhold Your
compassion from me; Your kindness and Your truth
shall constantly preserve me. Be pleased, O LORD,
to deliver me; O LORD, make haste to help me. Let 855R
those who seek to destroy my soul be ashamed and
confounded together; let those who desire my harm
retreat backward and be put to shame. May those
who say to me, “Aha! Aha!” be desolate because
of their shame.[2] But I am poor and needy; may the 860R
Lord consider me. You are my help and my deliverer;
O my God, do not delay. I said, “O LORD, be gra-
cious to me; heal my soul, for I have sinned against
You.” By this I know that You delight in me: that
my enemy does not shout in triumph over me. And 865R
You, O LORD, be gracious to me and raise me up,
that I may repay them.[3] Blessed be the LORD, God
of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting. Amen and

[1]The Hebrew כָּל תַּאֲוָתִי could be translated as “all my longing” or “all my yearning,” emphasizing not just desires but deep spiritual and physical needs brought before God.
[2]The Hebrew phrase הָאֹמְרִים לִי הֶאָח הֶאָח refers to expressions of malicious glee at another’s misfortune. In the context of illness, this would refer to those who might take satisfaction in the sick person’s suffering.
[3]The phrase וַאֲשַׁלְּמָה לָהֶם (“that I may repay them”) should not be understood as personal vengeance

[i]The self-description as “a stranger with You, a sojourner like all my fathers” reflects the transience of human life, a theme particularly relevant in Ma’avar Yabok’s approach to death as a transition or crossing over, similar to how the biblical patriarchs were sojourners.
[ii]The self-identification as “poor and needy” is not merely about material poverty but represents spiritual humility before God. In the context of illness, this phrase acknowledges human vulnerability and dependency on divine assistance.
[iii]The connection between healing and sin reflects Ma’avar Yabok’s theological framework that illness can serve as atonement. This verse acknowledges sin while simultaneously requesting healing, embodying the book’s approach to illness as potentially spiritually redemptive.
[iv]This powerful metaphor of a deer thirsting for water streams portrays spiritual longing in physical terms. For the sick or dying person, this image captures both physical need and spiritual yearning for divine refreshment.
[v]The reflexive question “Why are you cast down, O my soul?” represents an internal dialogue where the psalmist addresses their own spiritual distress. This provides a model for the sick person to engage their own spiritual struggles while maintaining hope.

וְרִיבָה רִיבִי מִגּוֹי לֹא חָסִיד מֵאִישׁ מִרְמָה וְעַוְלָה תְּפַלְּטֵנִי: כִּי אַתָּה אֱלֹהֵי מָעוּזִּי לָמָּה זְנַחְתָּנִי לָמָּה קֹדֵר אֶתְהַלֵּךְ בְּלַחַץ אוֹיֵב: [i]

Amen. As a deer longs for flowing streams, so my soul longs for You, O God. Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why do you moan within me? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him, the salvation of my countenance.[1] Judge me, O God, and plead my cause against an ungodly nation; from the deceitful and unjust man, deliver me.[2] For You are the God of my refuge; why have You cast me off? Why do I walk in gloom under the oppression of the enemy? 870R 875R

(כתובים) כִּי אֹרֶךְ יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם יוֹסִיפוּ לָךְ: [ii] בְּכָל דְּרָכֶיךָ דָעֵהוּ וְהוּא יְיַשֵּׁר אֹרְחֹתֶיךָ: [iii] וְיִמָּלְאוּ אֲסָמֶיךָ שָׂבָע וְתִירוֹשׁ יְקָבֶיךָ יִפְרָצוּ: [iv] מוּסַר יְיָ בְּנִי אַל תִּמְאָס וְאַל תָּקֹץ

For length of days, years of life, and peace they will add to you.[3] In all your ways know Him,[4] and He will make your paths straight. Your storehouses will be filled with plenty, and your vats will overflow with new wine. My son, do not reject the discipline of the LORD, nor loathe His reproof.[A] Then you will 880R

[A] Or: "My son, do not spurn the LORD's discipline or resent His correction" — This alternate

but as a desire to fulfill one's spiritual obligations and demonstrate God's justice through restoration.

[1] The Hebrew phrase יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנָיו could also be translated as "the salvation of His face" or "the help of His presence." I chose "salvation of my countenance" to capture how divine salvation is reflected in the changed countenance of the one who receives it.

[2] The psalm uses singular forms ("man") while also referring to "an ungodly nation," suggesting both individual and collective opposition to the righteous sufferer. This reflects the experience of the ill person who may face both specific challenges and broader systemic difficulties.

[3] The 'they' refers to the teachings of wisdom mentioned in the preceding verses of Proverbs, which are not included in this selection.

[4] The Hebrew 'דָּעֵהוּ' implies more than intellectual knowledge; it suggests acknowledging, recognizing, and being mindful of God in every aspect of life.

[i] Cf. Psalm 37:10-40 — These verses are selected to provide comfort to the sick or dying person by emphasizing divine justice and protection for the righteous. The text reassures that even though the wicked may temporarily prosper, their success is fleeting, while the righteous receive divine support. | Cf. Psalm 38:10, 2 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses give voice to the sick person's physical suffering while acknowledging divine judgment, creating a bridge between suffering and hope. | Cf. Psalm 38:16, 22-23 — These selections create a spiritual framework for the sick person to express both their suffering and their faith that God will respond to their prayers. | Cf. Psalm 39:8-13 — This selection helps the sick person contextualize their illness within the broader human condition of mortality while still appealing to divine mercy. | Cf. Psalm 40:2, 12-18 — This selection creates a progression from patient waiting to urgent need, mirroring the experience of serious illness that may be worsening. | Cf. Psalm 41:5, 12-14 — This psalm is particularly relevant for the sick as it directly addresses physical healing and restoration, providing hope that God will raise the person from their sickbed. | Cf. Psalm 42:2-3 — This passage expresses the soul's yearning for divine connection, particularly poignant for someone who may feel spiritually isolated due to illness. | Cf. Psalm 43:1-2 — This selection gives voice to the sick person's feelings of abandonment while still affirming God as their ultimate refuge.

[ii] This begins a collection of verses from Proverbs that emphasize divine blessing and protection. The opening verse (Proverbs 3:2) promises longevity, a significant theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to healing prayers.

[iii] From Proverbs 3:6, this verse emphasizes that recognizing God in all aspects of life leads to divine guidance, creating a theological framework where acknowledging divine providence is essential for healing.

[iv] From Proverbs 3:10, this verse uses agricultural abundance as a metaphor for divine blessing, connecting physical prosperity with spiritual wellbeing.

בְּתוֹכְחֹתוֹ׃[i] אַז תֵּלֵךְ לָבֶטַח
דַּרְכֶּךָ וְרַגְלְךָ לֹא תִגּוֹף׃[ii] אִם
תִּשְׁכַּב לֹא תִפְחָד וְשָׁכַבְתָּ וְעָרְבָה
שְׁנָתֶךָ׃[iii] אַל תִּירָא מִפַּחַד פִּתְאֹם
וּמִשֹּׁאַת רְשָׁעִים כִּי תָבֹא׃[iv] כִּי
יְהוָה יִהְיֶה בְכִסְלֶךָ וְשָׁמַר רַגְלְךָ
מִלָּכֶד׃[v] תְּתֵן לְרֹאשְׁךָ לִוְיַת
חֵן עֲטָרֹת תִּפְאֶרֶת תְּמַגְּנֶךָּ׃[vi]
בְּלֶכְתְּךָ לֹא יַצַר צַעֲדֶךָ וְאִם תָּרוּץ
לֹא תִכָּשֵׁל׃[vii] וְאַרַח צַדִּיקִים
כְּאוֹר נֹגַהּ הוֹלֵךְ וָאוֹר עַד נְכוֹן
הַיּוֹם׃[viii][ix]

walk securely on your way, and your foot will not stumble. When you lie down, you will not be afraid; 885R
when you lie down, your sleep will be sweet.[A] Do not be afraid of sudden terror, nor of the destruction of the wicked when it comes. For the LORD will be your confidence,[1] and will keep your foot from being caught. He will give to your head a garland of grace, 890R
a crown of glory He will shield you with.[2] When you walk, your step will not be hampered, and if you run, you will not stumble. The path of the righteous is like the light of dawn, shining brighter and brighter until the full day.[B] 895R

translation uses 'spurn' and 'resent' which more directly convey the emotional response warned against, and may better capture the nuance of rejecting divine correction through illness.

[A] Or: "When you lie down, you will not be fearful; you will lie down and your sleep will be pleasant" — This alternate translation avoids the repetition of 'when you lie down' in the English rendering while maintaining the parallelism of the Hebrew. The term 'pleasant' for 'עָרְבָה' captures the sense of comfortable, undisturbed rest.

[B] Or: "The path of the righteous is like the first gleam of morning light, growing ever brighter

[1] The Hebrew 'בְּכִסְלֶךָ' has multiple meanings including 'at your side/flank,' 'your confidence,' and 'your support,' suggesting God's intimate protective presence.

[2] The Hebrew 'תְּמַגְּנֶךָּ' (shield you) creates a unique image where the crown not only adorns but also protects, combining honor and defense in one metaphor.

[i] From Proverbs 3:11, this verse connects to Ma'avar Yabok's view that illness can be a form of divine discipline that should be accepted rather than rejected, as it serves a purifying spiritual purpose.

[ii] From Proverbs 3:23, this verse uses the metaphor of secure walking to represent divine protection from harm.

[iii] From Proverbs 3:24, this verse about peaceful sleep would be particularly meaningful to the sick or dying who might struggle with rest due to physical discomfort or spiritual anxiety.

[iv] From Proverbs 3:25, this verse addresses the fear of sudden calamity, offering reassurance particularly relevant to those experiencing acute illness or facing death.

[v] From Proverbs 3:26, the term 'בְּכִסְלֶךָ' (your confidence/strength/flank) is significant as it suggests God's intimate presence as a protecting force.

[vi] This combines elements from Proverbs 1:9 and 4:9, describing Torah wisdom as both ornamental ('garland of grace') and protective ('shield you'), reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's view that spiritual wisdom provides both dignity and defense.

[vii] From Proverbs 4:12, this verse uses the metaphor of unhindered movement to represent freedom from obstacles, which in the context of healing prayers suggests recovery from physical limitations caused by illness.

[viii] From Proverbs 4:18, this concluding verse uses the metaphor of increasing light to represent the progressive spiritual illumination of the righteous. In the context of healing prayers, it suggests that following divine wisdom leads to growing clarity and ultimately complete spiritual wellness.

[ix] Cf. Proverbs 3:2-26, 4:9-18 — The compiler has carefully selected verses that emphasize divine protection, guidance, and blessing, creating a therapeutic progression from accepting divine discipline to experiencing security and ultimately spiritual illumination. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's approach of using scripture to both comfort the sick and reinforce its theological framework that illness can serve as spiritual refinement. | Cf. Psalms 91 — These Proverbs verses share thematic connections with Psalm 91, particularly in their emphasis on divine protection from fear, harm, and sudden calamity. Both texts are employed in Ma'avar Yabok as sources of spiritual comfort and protection for the vulnerable. | Cf. Zohar III:158a — Ma'avar Yabok draws on Zoharic influences in its understanding of how spiritual wisdom provides both physical and metaphysical protection. These Proverbs verses emphasize that following divine wisdom creates a protective shield around the person, a concept central to kabbalistic thought.

לְפָנֶיךָ תְּבֹא תְּפִלָּתֵנוּ צוּר חַי
הָעוֹלָמִים: [i] הַקְשֵׁב תְּפִלַּת עֲבָדֶיךָ
וְלֹא נֵצֵא נִכְלָמִים: [ii] וְהַשְׁקִיפָה
עָלֵינוּ בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ מִמְּרוֹמִים: אֵל
חַי וְקַיָּם מֶלֶךְ יוֹשֵׁב עַל כִּסֵּא
רַחֲמִים: [iii]

May our prayer come before You,[1] Rock of Eternal Life. Hearken to the prayer of Your servants, and let us not depart ashamed. Look down upon us[2] with Your mercy from on high. Living and Enduring God, King who sits upon the throne of mercy.[3] 900R

סדר ליום שלישי

Order for Tuesday[4]

יתחיל פסוקי אנא ה׳ ואח״כ יאמר זה [iv]

One should begin with the verses of "Ana Hashem"[5] [Please, O LORD] and afterward recite this

(תהלים לה) לְדָוִד רִיבָה יְיָ
אֶת־יְרִיבַי לְחַם אֶת־לֹחֲמָי: הַחֲזֵק
מָגֵן וְצִנָּה וְקוּמָה בְּעֶזְרָתִי: וְהָרֵק
חֲנִית וּסְגֹר לִקְרַאת רדְפַי אֱמֹר
לְנַפְשִׁי יְשֻׁעָתֵךְ אָנִי: יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיִכָּלְמוּ
מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר וְיַחְפְּרוּ
חֹשְׁבֵי רָעָתִי: יִהְיוּ כְּמֹץ לִפְנֵי־רוּחַ
וּמַלְאַךְ יְיָ דּוֹחֶה: יְהִי־דַרְכָּם חֹשֶׁךְ
וַחֲלַקְלַקּוֹת וּמַלְאַךְ יְיָ רדְפָם:

(Psalm 35) Of David. Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me; fight against those who fight against me. Take hold of shield and buckler, and rise up to help me. Draw the spear and block the way against my pursuers; say to my soul, "I am your salvation." May those who seek my life be put to shame and dishonored; may those who plan evil against me be turned back and confounded. May they be like chaff before the wind, with the angel of the LORD 905R 910R

until the full light of day" — This alternate translation more vividly captures the progressive nature of the metaphor, emphasizing the gradual illumination from first light to full daylight, which better conveys the sense of spiritual growth and progressive healing intended in the context of Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] The Hebrew formulation תְּבֹא תְּפִלָּתֵנוּ literally means "may our prayer come/enter," invoking the image of prayer as something that physically travels to reach the divine presence.

[2] The Hebrew verb וְהַשְׁקִיפָה ("look down") often carries negative connotations in biblical Hebrew when referring to divine observation, but here it is specifically paired with "mercy" to transform it into a positive request for divine attention.

[3] This prayer concludes with this powerful image of God enthroned specifically on mercy rather than judgment, creating a fitting transition to the verses that follow in the larger prayer sequence.

[4] This heading introduces the prayer sequence designated for Tuesday (the third day of the week) in Ma'avar Yabok. It's part of the structured daily prayer system organized by days of the week that appears in section 7.16 of the text.

[5] The phrase 'Ana Hashem' (אנא ה׳) literally means 'Please, O LORD' and refers to a specific set of opening verses that begin each of the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok. These standardized opening prayers create ritual continuity throughout the book's organized prayer system.

[i] The phrase "Rock of Eternal Life" combines two divine epithets: "Rock" (צוּר), which refers to God's strength and reliability, and "Life of the Worlds" (חֵי הָעוֹלָמִים), emphasizing God as the source of all existence and life.

[ii] The petition not to "depart ashamed" reflects the vulnerability of the petitioner, possibly referring to the sick or dying person who fears rejection of their prayer.

[iii] The image of God sitting on a "throne of mercy" contrasts with the concept of God sitting on a "throne of judgment" (כִּסֵּא דִין), expressing hope that divine mercy will prevail over strict justice, particularly important in the context of illness or approaching death.

[iv] This is a liturgical instruction appearing in the context of prayers for the sick, specifically for Tuesday according to the previous context. It directs the reader to begin with a set of verses that start with the formula 'Ana Hashem' (Please, O LORD) before proceeding to the next prayer.

כִּי־חִנָּם טָמְנוּ־לִי שַׁחַת רִשְׁתָּם
חִנָּם חָפְרוּ לְנַפְשִׁי: תְּבוֹאֵהוּ
שׁוֹאָה לֹא־יֵדָע[i] וְרִשְׁתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר־טָמַן
תִּלְכְּדוֹ בְּשׁוֹאָה יִפָּל־בָּהּ: וְנַפְשִׁי
תָּגִיל בַּיהוָה תָּשִׂישׂ בִּישׁוּעָתוֹ:
כָּל עַצְמוֹתַי תֹּאמַרְנָה יְיָ מִי
כָמוֹךָ מַצִּיל עָנִי מֵחָזָק מִמֶּנּוּ
וְעָנִי וְאֶבְיוֹן מִגֹּזְלוֹ: יְקוּמוּן עֵדֵי
חָמָס אֲשֶׁר לֹא־יָדָעְתִּי יִשְׁאָלוּנִי:
יְשַׁלְּמוּנִי רָעָה תַּחַת טוֹבָה שְׁכוֹל
לְנַפְשִׁי: וַאֲנִי בַּחֳלוֹתָם לְבוּשִׁי
שָׂק עִנֵּיתִי בַצּוֹם נַפְשִׁי וּתְפִלָּתִי
עַל־חֵיקִי תָּשׁוּב[ii]: כְּרֵעַ־כְּאָח
לִי הִתְהַלָּכְתִּי כַּאֵבֶל־אֵם קֹדֵר
שַׁחוֹתִי: וּבְצַלְעִי שָׂמְחוּ וְנֶאֱסָפוּ
נֶאֱסְפוּ עָלַי נַכִּים וְלֹא יָדָעְתִּי
קָרְעוּ וְלֹא־דָמּוּ[iii]: בְּחַנְפֵי
לַעֲגֵי מָעוֹג חָרֹק עָלַי שִׁנַּימוֹ[iv]:
אֲדֹנָי כַּמָּה תִּרְאֶה חָשִׂיבָה נַפְשִׁי
מִשֹּׁאֵיהֶם מִכְּפִירִים יְחִידָתִי: אוֹדְךָ
בְּקָהָל רָב בְּעַם עָצוּם אֲהַלְלֶךָּ:
אַל־יִשְׂמְחוּ־לִי אֹיְבַי שֶׁקֶר שֹׂנְאַי

driving them away.[1] May their way be dark and slippery, with the angel of the LORD pursuing them. 915R
For without cause they hid their net for me; without cause they dug a pit for my life. May ruin come upon them unawares, and may the net that they hid ensnare them; into that very destruction let them fall. Then my soul shall rejoice in the LORD and exult 920R
in His salvation. All my bones shall say, “O LORD, who is like You, who rescues the poor from those stronger than they, the poor and needy from those who rob them?” Violent witnesses rise up; they ask me about things I do not know.[A] They repay me evil 925R
for good, bringing bereavement to my soul.[2] But I, when they were ill, clothed myself in sackcloth; I afflicted myself with fasting, and my prayer returned to my own bosom.[B] I walked about as though grieving for a friend or brother;[3] I bowed down in mourn- 930R
ing, as one who laments his mother. But when I stumbled, they gathered in glee; attackers gathered against me unbeknownst to me; they tore at me without ceasing. With godless mocking jesters, they gnashed their teeth at me.[C] O Lord, how long will 935R

[A] Or: “Malicious witnesses rise up; they demand answers about matters I am unaware of” — This translation better captures the legal context implied in the Hebrew, where false witnesses in a formal proceeding are making accusations that the psalmist cannot address because they are fabricated.

[B] Or: “and my prayer constantly returned to me” — This alternative captures the cyclical, persistent nature of the prayer implied in the Hebrew, suggesting continuous prayer rather than just its physical posture or return benefit.

[C] Or: “Among profane mockers at feasts, they grind their teeth against me” — This alterna-

[1] In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this image of divine angelic intervention would be particularly significant, as the book frequently describes angels as protecting the soul during moments of vulnerability, especially during illness and at death.

[2] The Hebrew “שְׁכוֹל לְנַפְשִׁי” literally means “bereavement to my soul,” suggesting not just emotional pain but a profound spiritual emptiness. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this could be understood as the spiritual distress that accompanies physical suffering.

[3] This verse illustrates the psalmist’s ethical ideal of treating others with compassion even when they are enemies—a principle that aligns with Ma’avar Yabok’s emphasis on proper treatment of all human beings, including enemies, based on their inherent divine spark.

[i] This phrase uses the imagery of unexpected catastrophe (shoah), which would later become the Hebrew term for the Holocaust. In this psalm, it refers to divine retribution that comes upon the evildoer without warning.

[ii] This verse demonstrates the psalmist’s compassion for his enemies during their illness, creating a stark contrast with their treatment of him. The phrase “my prayer returned to my bosom” is enigmatic in Hebrew and has been interpreted variously as referring to prayer that returns to benefit the one who prays, or to a posture of prayer with head bowed to the chest.

[iii] This difficult verse contains several rare terms. The word “נַכִּים” (nekhim) appears only here in the Hebrew Bible and likely refers to smiters or attackers. The phrase “קָרְעוּ וְלֹא־דָמּוּ” literally means “they tear and do not cease,” indicating relentless verbal attacks.

[iv] This is one of the most challenging verses to translate in the psalm. The term “מָעוֹג” (ma’og) is a hapax legomenon (appears only once in the Hebrew Bible). The phrase likely refers to impious mockers at feasts, suggesting people who profane sacred gatherings with their mockery.

חִנָּם יִקְרְצוּ־עָיִן: כִּי לֹא שָׁלוֹם
יְדַבֵּרוּ וְעַל רִגְעֵי־אֶרֶץ דִּבְרֵי
מִרְמוֹת יַחֲשֹׁבוּן[i]: וַיִּרְחִיבוּ עָלַי
פִּיהֶם אָמְרוּ הֶאָח הֶאָח רָאֲתָה
עֵינֵינוּ: רָאִיתָה יְיָ אַל־תֶּחֱרַשׁ
אֲדֹנָי אַל־תִּרְחַק מִמֶּנִּי: הָעִירָה
וְהָקִיצָה לְמִשְׁפָּטִי אֱלֹהַי וַאדֹנָי
לְרִיבִי: שָׁפְטֵנִי כְצִדְקְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהָי
וְאַל־יִשְׂמְחוּ־לִי: אַל־יֹאמְרוּ בְלִבָּם
הֶאָח נַפְשֵׁנוּ אַל־יֹאמְרוּ בִלַּעְנוּהוּ:
יֵבשׁוּ וְיַחְפְּרוּ יַחְדָּו שְׂמֵחֵי רָעָתִי
יִלְבְּשׁוּ־בֹשֶׁת וּכְלִמָּה הַמַּגְדִּילִים
עָלָי: יָרֹנּוּ וְיִשְׂמְחוּ חֲפֵצֵי צִדְקִי
וְיֹאמְרוּ תָמִיד יִגְדַּל יְיָ הֶחָפֵץ
שְׁלוֹם עַבְדּוֹ: וּלְשׁוֹנִי תֶּהְגֶּה צִדְקֶךָ
כָּל־הַיּוֹם תְּהִלָּתֶךָ: [ii]

You look on? Rescue my soul from their ravages, my precious life from the lions.[1] I will give You thanks in the great congregation; I will praise You among the mighty throng. Let not those rejoice over me who are wrongfully my foes, nor let those who hate me without cause wink the eye. For they do not speak peace, but against the quiet ones of the land they devise words of deceit. They open wide their mouths against me; they say, "Aha, Aha, our eyes have seen it!" You have seen, O LORD; do not be silent! O Lord, do not be far from me! Awake and rouse Yourself for my judgment,[2] my God and my Lord, for my cause! Judge me according to Your righteousness, O LORD my God, and let them not rejoice over me. Let them not say in their hearts, "Aha, just what we wanted!" Let them not say, "We have swallowed him up." May all who rejoice at my calamity be put to shame and confounded; may those who exalt themselves against me be clothed with shame and dishonor. Let those who delight in my vindication shout for joy and be glad; let them say continually, "Great is the LORD, who delights in the well-being of His servant." Then my tongue shall declare Your righteousness and Your praise all day long.

(תורה) וַתַּעַן לָהֶם מִרְיָם שִׁירוּ
לַייָ כִּי גָאֹה גָּאָה סוּס וְרֹכְבוֹ

(Torah) And Miriam answered them,[3] "Sing to the LORD, for He is highly exalted; the horse and its

tive interprets the difficult term 'ma'og' as referring to feasts or cakes, following some rabbinic interpretations, which gives a more specific context to the mockery being described.

[1] The Hebrew "יְחִידָתִי" (yeḥidati) literally means "my only one" and refers to the precious, irreplaceable nature of one's life or soul.

[2] This metaphorical language of divine awakening appears frequently in Jewish liturgy, especially in prayers for the sick and dying. It represents a call for divine intervention in human affairs when justice seems delayed.

[3] This verse (Exodus 15:21) comes from the Song at the Sea after the crossing of the Red Sea, where Miriam led the women in celebration with tambourines and dancing.

[i] The phrase "רִגְעֵי־אֶרֶץ" (rig'ei-eretz) is difficult to translate precisely. It may refer to "the quiet of the land" (peaceful inhabitants) or "the moments/affairs of the land." I've translated it as "quiet ones of the land" referring to peaceful citizens who become targets of the wicked.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 71 — In Ma'avar Yabok, Psalm 71 appears in the sixth liturgical order (Seder Vav) as another psalm recommended for recitation by or for the sick. The structural parallels between these psalms highlight the recurring pattern in which the psalmist appeals to God for defense against those who seek harm. | Cf. Zohar — In Ma'avar Yabok's mystical framework, the angels mentioned in this psalm would be understood as real spiritual entities that can be summoned through proper prayer and meditation to protect the ill person and guide the soul through difficult transitions. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The inclusion of Psalm 35 for Tuesday (associated with the divine attribute of Tiferet/Harmony) suggests it was understood to have special efficacy in balancing divine judgment with mercy for the benefit of the ill person. | Cf. Talmud Berakhot — Ma'avar Yabok's ethical framework emphasizes that proper care for the sick and dying extends even to those with whom one has conflict, mirroring the psalmist's compassionate response to his enemies' suffering.

רָמָה בַיָּם: דַּבֵּר אֶלֵהֶם לֵאמֹר בֵּין
הָעַרְבַּיִם תֹּאכְלוּ בָשָׂר וּבַבֹּקֶר
תִּשְׂבְּעוּ לָחֶם וִידַעְתֶּם כִּי אֲנִי יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵיכֶם: וַיְהִי בָעֶרֶב וַתַּעַל הַשְּׂלָו
וַתְּכַס אֶת הַמַּחֲנֶה וּבַבֹּקֶר הָיְתָה
שִׁכְבַת הַטַּל סָבִיב לַמַּחֲנֶה: וַתַּעַל
שִׁכְבַת הַטַּל וְהִנֵּה עַל פְּנֵי הַמִּדְבָּר
דַּק מְחֻסְפָּס[i] דַּק כַּכְּפֹר עַל הָאָרֶץ:
וַיִּרְאוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וַיֹּאמְרוּ אִישׁ
אֶל אָחִיו מָן הוּא[ii] כִּי לֹא יָדְעוּ
מַה הוּא: וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה אֲלֵהֶם הוּא
הַלֶּחֶם אֲשֶׁר נָתַן יְיָ לָכֶם לְאָכְלָה:
וַיִּבֶן מֹשֶׁה מִזְבֵּחַ וַיִּקְרָא שְׁמוֹ יְיָ
נִסִּי:[iii] וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה אֶל הָעָם
אַל תִּירְאוּ כִּי לְבַעֲבוּר נַסּוֹת
אֶתְכֶם בָּא הָאֱלֹהִים וּבַעֲבוּר תִּהְיֶה
יִרְאָתוֹ עַל פְּנֵיכֶם לְבִלְתִּי תֶחֱטָאוּ:
בְּכָל הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר אַזְכִּיר אֶת שְׁמִי
אָבוֹא אֵלֶיךָ וּבֵרַכְתִּיךָ:[iv]

rider He has hurled into the sea." "Speak to them saying: 'At twilight you shall eat meat,[1] and in the morning you shall be satisfied with bread. Then you shall know that I am the LORD your God.'" And at 965R evening the quails came up and covered the camp, and in the morning there was a layer of dew around the camp. When the layer of dew evaporated, behold, on the surface of the wilderness there was a fine flake-like thing,[A] fine as the frost on the ground. 970R When the children of Israel saw it, they said to one another, "What is it?"[2] For they did not know what it was. And Moses said to them, "It is the bread which the LORD has given you to eat." And Moses built an altar[3] and called its name "The LORD is 975R my banner." And Moses said to the people, "Do not fear, for God has come to test you,[B] and that His fear may be before your faces, so that you may not sin." "In every place where I cause My name to be remembered, I will come to you and bless you."[4] 980R

וְקוֵי יְיָ יַחֲלִיפוּ כֹחַ (נביאים) But those who hope in the LORD will renew their

[A] Or: "fine and granular" — The term מְחֻסְפָּס appears only once in the Bible and has been variously translated as 'granular,' 'scale-like,' or 'peeled.' The translation 'granular' might better capture the physical appearance being described.

[B] Or: "for God has come to prove you" — The Hebrew verb נָסוֹת can mean 'to test' but also carries connotations of 'proving' or 'demonstrating' one's faith. In this context, God is not merely testing the Israelites but providing an opportunity for them to demonstrate their faith.

[1] This passage (Exodus 16:12-15) describes God's promise to provide quail in the evening and manna in the morning for the Israelites in the wilderness.

[2] This is a wordplay in Hebrew, as 'mān hū' ('what is it?') sounds like the word 'manna,' which became the name for this miraculous food.

[3] This verse (Exodus 17:15) appears after the battle with Amalek, where Moses' raised hands (supported by Aaron and Hur) ensured Israel's victory.

[4] This final verse (Exodus 20:21) establishes the principle of divine presence at sanctified places of worship.

[i] The term מְחֻסְפָּס (mechuspas) appears only once in the Bible and its precise meaning is debated. It seems to describe the texture or appearance of the manna as being fine and flake-like, possibly from a root meaning 'peeled' or 'scaled.'

[ii] The Hebrew phrase 'man hu' (מָן הוּא) literally means 'What is it?' and is the origin of the term 'manna.'

[iii] The name 'YHWH Nissi' means 'The LORD is my banner,' signifying divine protection and leadership, particularly in battle contexts.

[iv] Cf. Exodus 15-20 — This compilation strings together verses from the Exodus narrative that highlight God's miraculous provisions (manna, quail), protection (victory over Amalek), and presence (at Sinai). These verses would comfort someone who is ill by reminding them of God's power to sustain, protect, and remain present with the faithful. | Cf. Psalms 78:23-25 — The passage about manna connects to Psalm 78's poetic description of manna as 'bread of heaven' and 'food of angels,' enhancing the spiritual significance of God's provision in the wilderness as a sign of divine care and sustenance. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:11-16 — In Ma'avar Yabok, passages from Song of Songs are used during tahara rituals (washing the deceased), suggesting these Exodus verses might similarly provide spiritual nourishment and comfort during illness or preparation for death.

יַעֲלוּ אֵבֶר כַּנְּשָׁרִים יָרוּצוּ וְלֹא
יִיגְעוּ יֵלְכוּ וְלֹא יִיעָפוּ: אַל תִּירָא
כִּי עִמְּךָ אָנִי אַל תִּשְׁתָּע[i] כִּי אֲנִי
אֱלֹהֶיךָ אִמַּצְתִּיךָ אַף עֲזַרְתִּיךָ אַף
תְּמַכְתִּיךָ בִּימִין צִדְקִי: הֵן יֵבֹשׁוּ
וְיִכָּלְמוּ כֹּל הַנֶּחֱרִים בָּךְ יִהְיוּ כְאַיִן
וְיֹאבְדוּ אַנְשֵׁי רִיבֶךָ תְּבַקְשֵׁם וְלֹא
תִמְצָאֵם[ii] אַנְשֵׁי מַצֻּתֶךָ יִהְיוּ כְאַיִן
וּכְאֶפֶס אַנְשֵׁי מִלְחַמְתֶּךָ: כִּי אֲנִי
יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ מַחֲזִיק יְמִינֶךָ הָאֹמֵר
לְךָ אַל תִּירָא אֲנִי עֲזַרְתִּיךָ: תְּזֹרֵם
וְרוּחַ תִּשָּׂאֵם[iii] וּסְעָרָה תָּפִיץ אוֹתָם
וְאַתָּה תָּגִיל בַּיהוָה בִּקְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל
תִּתְהַלָּל: אָנֹכִי אָנֹכִי יְהוָה וְאֵין
מִבַּלְעָדַי מוֹשִׁיעַ: יְהוָה חָפֵץ לְמַעַן
צִדְקוֹ יַגְדִּיל תּוֹרָה וְיַאְדִּיר: [iv]

strength; they will soar on wings like eagles;[1] they will run and not grow weary, they will walk and not be faint. Fear not, for I am with you; be not dismayed, for I am your God; I will strengthen you, yes, I will help you, yes, I will uphold you with My righteous right hand.[2] Behold, all who are incensed against you shall be ashamed and disgraced;[3] those who contend with you shall be as nothing and shall perish. You will seek them but not find them—those who quarrel with you; those who war against you will be as nothing, as a thing of naught. For I, the LORD your God, hold your right hand; I am He who says to you, "Fear not, I will help you." You shall winnow them, and the wind shall carry them away, and the storm shall scatter them. And you shall rejoice in the LORD; in the Holy One of Israel you shall glory. I, even I, am the LORD, and besides Me there is no savior. The LORD desired, for the sake of His righteousness, to magnify the Torah and make it glorious.[4]

985R 990R 995R 1000R

[1] The eagle imagery has special resonance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it connects to the soul's ascent after death. Just as eagles soar effortlessly, the properly prepared soul can rise above physical limitations, especially at the moment of transition.

[2] In kabbalistic thought, God's "right hand" represents the attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness), while "righteousness" (tzedek) is associated with judgment tempered by mercy. This phrase thus conveys that divine support comes through the balanced interaction of mercy and justice.

[3] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, those "incensed against you" would be understood as spiritual accusers (mekatregim) that might stand against the soul in the heavenly court. This verse promises their defeat when one is supported by divine presence.

[4] This concluding verse carries special significance in Ma'avar Yabok, suggesting that proper spiritual preparation for death, including engagement with these verses with proper intention (kavvanah), actually fulfills divine purpose by magnifying Torah even in one's final moments.

[i] This relatively rare biblical term (אַל תִּשְׁתָּע) from Isaiah 41:10 means "be not dismayed" or "do not look around in anxiety." Its uncommon nature makes it particularly significant in this prayer sequence, emphasizing the spiritual directive to maintain focused trust rather than anxious distraction when facing illness or death.

[ii] This phrase "you shall seek them but not find them" would be understood in the context of Ma'avar Yabok as referring not just to physical enemies but to spiritual accusers or negative forces that might impede the soul's journey. The promise of their complete disappearance would be particularly comforting to someone approaching death.

[iii] The winnowing imagery here, where enemies are scattered like chaff in the wind, has kabbalistic significance in Ma'avar Yabok's framework. It suggests the divine power to separate the soul from negative spiritual attachments during the transition of death, allowing the essential self to rise unimpeded.

[iv] Cf. Isaiah 40:31 — This verse is likely included in Ma'avar Yabok to offer spiritual comfort and strength to the sick or dying person, suggesting that through divine connection they will find renewal even in weakness. | Cf. Isaiah 41:10-13 — These verses reassure the ill person of divine protection and presence, emphasizing that God will strengthen them in their weakened state and vanquish their spiritual enemies. | Cf. Isaiah 41:16 — This offers the hope that negative spiritual forces will be overcome, allowing the person to ultimately rejoice in divine presence. | Cf. Isaiah 43:11 — This reinforces that healing and salvation come only from God, directing the ill person to focus their hopes on divine intervention rather than merely physical remedies. | Cf. Isaiah 42:21 — This concluding verse connects suffering to divine purpose, suggesting that through proper spiritual engagement with Torah even in illness, one participates in the divine plan.

(תהלים) בְּךָ צָרֵינוּ נְנַגֵּחַ בְּשִׁמְךָ
נָבוּס קָמֵינוּ: כִּי הוֹשַׁעְתָּנוּ מִצָּרֵינוּ
וּמְשַׂנְאֵינוּ הֱבִישׁוֹתָ: עוֹרָה לָמָּה
תִישַׁן אֲדֹנָי הָקִיצָה אַל תִּזְנַח
לָנֶצַח: לָמָּה פָנֶיךָ תַסְתִּיר תִּשְׁכַּח
עָנְיֵנוּ וְלַחֲצֵנוּ: כִּי שָׁחָה לֶעָפָר
נַפְשֵׁנוּ דָּבְקָה לָאָרֶץ בִּטְנֵנוּ: קוּמָה
עֶזְרָתָה לָנוּ וּפְדֵנוּ לְמַעַן חַסְדֶּךָ:
אֱלֹהִים לָנוּ מַחֲסֶה וָעֹז עֶזְרָה
בְצָרוֹת נִמְצָא מְאֹד: יֵ צְבָאוֹת
עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה:
חֲגוֹר חַרְבְּךָ עַל יָרֵךְ גִּבּוֹר הוֹדְךָ
וַהֲדָרֶךָ: יַדְבֵּר עַמִּים תַּחְתֵּינוּ
וּלְאֻמִּים תַּחַת רַגְלֵינוּ: כִּי זֶה
אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהֵינוּ עוֹלָם וָעֶד הוּא
יְנַהֲגֵנוּ עַל מוּת:[i] אַךְ אֱלֹהִים
יִפְדֶּה נַפְשִׁי מִיַּד שְׁאוֹל[ii] כִּי יִקָּחֵנִי
סֶלָה: וּקְרָאֵנִי בְיוֹם צָרָה אֲחַלְּצֶךָּ
וּתְכַבְּדָנִי: חָנֵּנִי אֱלֹהִים כְּחַסְדֶּךָ
כְּרֹב רַחֲמֶיךָ מְחֵה פְשָׁעָי: תְּחַטְּאֵנִי
בְאֵזוֹב וְאֶטְהָר תְּכַבְּסֵנִי וּמִשֶּׁלֶג
אַלְבִּין: תַּשְׁמִיעֵנִי שָׂשׂוֹן וְשִׂמְחָה
תָּגֵלְנָה עֲצָמוֹת דִּכִּיתָ: הַסְתֵּר
פָּנֶיךָ מֵחֲטָאָי וְכָל עֲוֹנֹתַי מְחֵה:
לֵב טָהוֹר בְּרָא לִי אֱלֹהִים וְרוּחַ
נָכוֹן חַדֵּשׁ בְּקִרְבִּי: אַל תַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי
מִלְּפָנֶיךָ וְרוּחַ קָדְשְׁךָ אַל תִּקַּח
מִמֶּנִּי: הָשִׁיבָה לִי שְׂשׂוֹן יִשְׁעֶךָ

(Psalms) Through You we push back our adversaries; through Your name we trample our foes.[1] For You have saved us from our enemies, and have put to shame those who hate us. Awake! Why do You sleep,[2] O Lord? Arise! Do not cast us off forever. Why do You hide Your face and forget our affliction and our oppression? For our soul is bowed down to the dust; our belly clings to the earth.[A] Rise up, come to our help, and redeem us for the sake of Your steadfast love. God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble. The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress. Selah. Gird Your sword on Your thigh, O mighty one, in Your splendor and Your majesty. He will subdue peoples under us, and nations under our feet. For this God is our God forever and ever; He will guide us even unto death. Surely God will redeem my soul from the power of Sheol, for He will take me. Selah. Call upon Me in the day of trouble; I will deliver you, and you shall glorify Me.[B] Be gracious to me, O God, according to Your steadfast love; according to Your abundant mercy, blot out my transgressions. Purify me with hyssop, and I shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow. Let me hear joy and gladness; let the bones You have crushed rejoice.[C] Hide Your face from my sins, and blot out all my iniquities. Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a steadfast spirit within me. Do not cast

[A] Or: "our body cleaves to the ground" — While 'belly' is a literal translation of בִּטְנֵנוּ, in this context it represents the whole body prostrate in weakness or submission, so this alternate might better convey the intended meaning to modern readers.

[B] Or: "in the day of trouble; I will rescue you, and you shall honor Me" — The alternate translation uses 'rescue' instead of 'deliver' for אֲחַלְּצֶךָּ and 'honor' instead of 'glorify' for וּתְכַבְּדָנִי, providing slightly more accessible language while maintaining the meaning.

[C] Or: "Let me hear sounds of joy and gladness; let the bones You have broken dance with delight" — This more expansive translation captures the vivid contrast between crushed bones and their subsequent rejoicing, emphasizing the paradoxical transformation that suffering can bring—a theme important in Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] The Hebrew uses vivid, aggressive language of 'goring' (נְנַגֵּחַ) and 'trampling' (נָבוּס) enemies, reflecting the spiritual battle metaphor often employed in prayers for the sick, who are understood to be fighting against both physical illness and spiritual forces.

[2] This anthropomorphic language of God 'sleeping' reflects the common biblical expression of divine absence or perceived inaction during suffering. In the context of prayers for the sick, it represents the patient's feeling of abandonment that requires spiritual reassurance.

[i] This phrase could be interpreted either as "unto death" or as a reference to the musical term "Alamoth" found in psalm superscriptions. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the former interpretation connecting to death and transition would be more significant.

[ii] The reference to being redeemed "from the hand of Sheol" has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of preparing for death, suggesting that proper spiritual preparation can transform the experience of death from punishment to redemption.

וְרוּחַ נְדִיבָה תִּסְמְכֵנִי: אֲדֹנָי שְׂפָתַי
תִּפְתָּח וּפִי יַגִּיד תְּהִלָּתֶךָ: זִבְחֵי
אֱלֹהִים רוּחַ נִשְׁבָּרָה לֵב נִשְׁבָּר
920 וְנִדְכֶּה אֱלֹהִים לֹא תִבְזֶה:[i] וַאֲנִי
כְּזַיִת רַעֲנָן בְּבֵית אֱלֹהִים בָּטַחְתִּי
בְּחֶסֶד אֱלֹהִים עוֹלָם וָעֶד: מִי
יִתֵּן מִצִּיּוֹן יְשׁוּעַת יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּשׁוּב
אֱלֹהִים שְׁבוּת עַמּוֹ יָגֵל יַעֲקֹב
925 יִשְׂמַח יִשְׂרָאֵל: אוֹדְךָ לְעוֹלָם כִּי
עָשִׂיתָ וַאֲקַוֶּה שִׁמְךָ כִּי טוֹב נֶגֶד
חֲסִידֶיךָ: אֱלֹהִים שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי
הַאֲזִינָה לְאִמְרֵי פִי: כִּי מְכָל
צָרָה הִצִּילָנִי וּבְאֹיְבַי רָאֲתָה
930 עֵינִי: הַאֲזִינָה אֱלֹהִים תְּפִלָּתִי
וְאַל תִּתְעַלַּם מִתְּחִנָּתִי: הַקְשִׁיבָה
לִי וַעֲנֵנִי אָרִיד בְּשִׂיחִי וְאָהִימָה:
בַּלַּע אֲדָנָי פַּלַּג לְשׁוֹנָם כִּי רָאִיתִי
חָמָס וְרִיב בָּעִיר: אֲנִי אֶל אֱלֹהִים
935 אֶקְרָא וַיהוָה יוֹשִׁיעֵנִי: עֶרֶב וָבֹקֶר
וְצָהֳרַיִם אָשִׂיחָה וְאֶהֱמֶה[ii] וַיִּשְׁמַע
קוֹלִי: פָּדָה בְשָׁלוֹם נַפְשִׁי מִקְּרָב
לִי כִּי בְרַבִּים הָיוּ עִמָּדִי:[iii]

me away from Your presence, and do not take Your 1030R
Holy Spirit from me. Restore to me the joy of Your
salvation, and uphold me with a willing spirit. O
Lord, open my lips, and my mouth will declare Your
praise. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a
broken and contrite heart, O God, You will not de- 1035R
spise. But I am like a green olive tree in the house of
God; I trust in the steadfast love of God forever and
ever. Oh, that the salvation of Israel would come
from Zion! When God restores the fortunes of His
people, let Jacob rejoice, let Israel be glad. I will give 1040R
You thanks forever, because You have done it. I will
hope in Your name, for it is good, in the presence of
Your faithful ones. Hear my prayer, O God; give ear
to the words of my mouth. For He has delivered me
from every trouble, and my eye has looked in triumph 1045R
on my enemies. Give ear to my prayer, O God, and
do not hide Yourself from my supplication. Listen to
me and answer me; I am restless in my complaint and
I moan, because of the voice of the enemy, because
of the oppression of the wicked. O Lord, confuse and 1050R
divide their tongues, for I see violence and strife in
the city. As for me, I will call upon God, and the
LORD will save me. Evening and morning and at
noon I will pray and cry aloud, and He shall hear
my voice. He has redeemed my soul in peace from 1055R
the battle that was against me,[1] for there were many
against me."

[1]The compilation concludes with this powerful image of peaceful redemption from conflict, offering hope that even when surrounded by multiple adversaries (physical illness, spiritual doubts, fear of death), divine deliverance remains possible.

[i]This verse from Psalm 51:17 is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, which emphasizes internal contrition over external sacrifice, presenting a broken spirit and contrite heart as the most effective offering during illness.

[ii]This reference to praying three times daily connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on structured prayer times. In kabbalistic thought, these three prayer times correspond to the three patriarchs and different spiritual energies available throughout the day.

[iii]Cf. Psalm 44:5-8 — The beginning of this compilation quotes directly from Psalm 44, which is about national distress but confidence in divine deliverance. This sets the tone for the entire prayer sequence as one seeking divine intervention in times of trouble. | Cf. Psalm 51 — The inclusion of verses from Psalm 51 shifts the focus from external enemies to internal spiritual purification, suggesting that the sick person should examine their conscience and seek spiritual cleansing alongside physical healing. | Cf. Psalm 55:17-18 — These verses emphasize the importance of regular, structured prayer (evening, morning, and noon) even in times of distress, reinforcing a key practice for the sick person to maintain throughout their illness. | Cf. Psalm 48:14 — The phrase 'He will guide us even unto death' (עַל מוּת) could be a deliberate modification of Psalm 48:14's 'unto death' to emphasize divine guidance through the transition of death, connecting to Ma'avar Yabok's central theme of crossing over. | Cf. Psalm 52:8 — The image of the 'green olive tree in the house of God' contrasts with earlier imagery of being 'bowed down to the dust,' suggesting spiritual restoration and vitality even in the face of illness or approaching death.

(כתובים) יְהִי מְקוֹרֵךְ
בָּרוּךְ[i] וּשְׂמַח מֵאֵשֶׁת נְעוּרֶךָ:
בְּרָכוֹת לְרֹאשׁ צַדִּיק[ii] וּפִי רְשָׁעִים
יְכַסֶּה חָמָס: זֵכֶר צַדִּיק לִבָרָכָה
וְשֵׁם רְשָׁעִים יִרְקָב: בִּרְכַּת יְיָ
הִיא תַּעֲשִׁיר וְלֹא יוֹסִף עֶצֶב
עִמָּהּ:[iii] בְּהִתְהַלֶּכְךָ תַּנְחֶה אֹתָךְ
בְּשָׁכְבְּךָ תִּשְׁמֹר עָלֶיךָ וַהֲקִיצוֹתָ
הִיא תְּשִׂיחֶךָ: כִּי בִי יִרְבּוּ יָמֶיךָ
וְיוֹסִיפוּ לְךָ שְׁנוֹת חַיִּים: נֶפֶשׁ
בְּרָכָה תְּדֶשֶׁן וּמַרְוֶה גַּם הוּא
יוֹרֶא:[iv] מְאוֹר עֵינַיִם יְשַׂמַּח לֵב
שְׁמוּעָה טוֹבָה תְּדַשֵּׁן עָצֶם: לְאָדָם
מַעַרְכֵי לֵב וּמֵיְיָ מַעֲנֵה לָשׁוֹן: גֹּל
אֶל יְיָ מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וְיִכֹּנוּ מַחְשְׁבֹתֶיךָ:
רַבּוֹת מַחֲשָׁבוֹת בְּלֶב אִישׁ וַעֲצַת יְיָ
הִיא תָקוּם:[v]

(Writings) May your fountain be blessed, and rejoice with the wife of your youth.[1] Blessings are upon the head of the righteous, but the mouth of the wicked conceals violence. The memory of the righteous is a blessing,[2] but the name of the wicked will rot. The blessing of the LORD makes rich, and He adds no sorrow with it. When you walk, it shall guide you; when you lie down, it shall watch over you;[3] and when you awake, it shall talk with you. For by me your days shall be multiplied, and years of life shall be added to you. A generous soul will be made rich,[A] and he who waters will also be watered himself.[B] The light of the eyes rejoices the heart; good news refreshes the bones. The preparations of the heart belong to man, but the answer of the tongue is from the LORD. Commit your works to the LORD,[4] and your thoughts will be established. There are many plans in a man's heart, but the coun-

[A] Or: "A blessing soul will be enriched" — The Hebrew 'נֶפֶשׁ בְּרָכָה' could be understood either as 'a generous soul' (one who blesses others) or more literally as 'a soul of blessing.' This alternate translation preserves the ambiguity of whether the soul is giving or receiving blessing.

[B] Or: "and one who gives drink will also be drenched" — This alternate translation emphasizes the intensity of reciprocal blessing in the Hebrew text, where 'יוֹרֶא' suggests being thoroughly saturated rather than merely watered.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this reference to marital joy may take on additional meaning as an encouragement to reflect on life's blessings when facing illness or death.

[2] This verse is particularly significant in Jewish mourning traditions, where it is customary to add "may their memory be a blessing" after mentioning a deceased righteous person.

[3] While in its original context this refers to wisdom's protection during sleep, in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and death, this would be understood as divine protection extending even to one's final rest.

[4] The Hebrew גֹּל ("roll") creates a vivid image of rolling one's burdens onto God, suggesting complete surrender of one's efforts and outcomes to divine care—particularly meaningful for those facing illness or death.

[i] The "fountain" metaphor (מְקוֹר) is understood in rabbinic tradition to refer to both offspring and one's spiritual legacy, suggesting that righteousness leads to a blessed lineage and enduring impact.

[ii] This is part of a series of contrasts between the righteous and the wicked that appears in Proverbs, emphasizing how righteousness leads to blessing while wickedness leads to destruction.

[iii] This verse distinguishes divine blessing from worldly wealth, which often brings anxiety with it. Divine blessing enriches without the accompanying sorrow that typically comes with material prosperity.

[iv] This verse employs agricultural metaphors of watering and being watered to express the spiritual principle that generosity brings prosperity back to the giver.

[v] Cf. Proverbs 5:18 — The fountain metaphor represents offspring and marital blessing. This verse begins a compilation of wisdom sayings about righteous living and divine blessing. | Cf. Proverbs 10:6-7, 11:25, 15:30 — These verses are collected from various chapters of Proverbs to create a cohesive meditation on divine blessing and righteousness, particularly appropriate for reflection during illness. | Cf. Proverbs 6:22 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse would be understood as describing Torah's protection during life and even in death—"when you lie down" taking on additional meaning for the dying person. | Cf. Proverbs 16:1, 16:3, 19:21 — These verses emphasize surrendering to divine providence, particularly comforting for the sick or dying who must accept that their future rests in God's hands rather than their own plans.

sel of the LORD will stand.[1]

כְּאוֹב לֵבָב אֲנִי נִדְאָב וְנִכְאָב.[i] וְאֵין לִי אָב וְאַתָּה אָבִי וְקוֹנִי. לְךָ זָדִתִּי לְבַדֶּךָ[ii] וְנָדָדְתִּי וְדִמְעָתִי כְּמוֹ לֶחֶם מְזוֹנִי.[iii] יְרוּאוּנִי חֲסָדֶיךָ וְאֶחְיֶה וְהוֹשִׁיעָה יְמִינְךָ וַעֲנֵנִי:

With a pained heart I am sorrowful and afflicted.[2] I have no father but You are my father and my creator. Against You alone have I sinned and wandered,[3] and my tears are like my daily bread. May Your mercies come to me that I may live, and may Your right hand save me and answer me. 1080R

מנחה ליום שלישי

Afternoon Prayer for Tuesday[4]

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳ ואחר כך יאמר זה

One should recite the verses beginning with "Ana Hashem" [Please, O LORD] and afterward say this. 1085R

(תהלים נו) לַמְנַצֵּחַ עַל־יוֹנַת אִלֶּם רְחֹקִים לְדָוִד מִכְתָּם בֶּאֱחֹז אֹתוֹ פְלִשְׁתִּים בְּגַת: חָנֵּנִי אֱלֹהִים כִּי־שְׁאָפַנִי אֱנוֹשׁ כָּל־הַיּוֹם לוֹחֵם יִלְחָצֵנִי: שָׁאֲפוּ שׁוֹרְרַי כָּל־הַיּוֹם כִּי־רַבִּים לֹחֲמִים לִי מָרוֹם: יוֹם אִירָא אֲנִי אֵלֶיךָ אֶבְטָח: בֵּאלֹהִים

(Psalm 56) For the choirmaster. To the tune of "A Silent Dove of Distant Places."[A] A miktam[B] of David, when the Philistines seized him in Gath.[5] Be gracious to me, O God, for man tramples on me; all day long an attacker oppresses me. My enemies trample on me all day long, for many attack me from on high.[C] On the day I am afraid, I put my trust in 1090R

[A] Or: "For the leader; on "The Dove of Distant Terebinths."" — The Hebrew phrase יוֹנַת אִלֶּם רְחֹקִים is ambiguous and has been interpreted various ways. The word אִלֶּם can mean 'silent' but some scholars interpret it as referring to 'terebinth trees' (אֵלִים). This alternate translation reflects this scholarly interpretation, which is used in some modern translations.

[B] Or: "A golden psalm" — The term 'miktam' (מִכְתָּם) appears in several psalm titles but its exact meaning is uncertain. Some traditions interpret it as 'golden psalm' or 'inscription,' suggesting a particularly precious or permanent composition. This is a more interpretive translation that attempts to convey the term's possible meaning rather than simply transliterating it.

[C] Or: "My adversaries pant after me all day long, for many fight against me proudly" — The Hebrew verb שָׁאֲפוּ literally means 'they pant after' rather than 'trample.' Additionally, מָרוֹם could be interpreted as 'proudly/haughtily' rather than 'from on high.' This alternate translation is more literal to the Hebrew text while still capturing the sense of persecution.

[1] This concluding verse emphasizes divine sovereignty over human plans, offering both comfort and challenge to the sick or dying person to accept God's ultimate authority over their life's course.

[2] The Hebrew uses a triad of terms for pain and sorrow, creating a rhythmic intensification that is difficult to fully capture in translation.

[3] This confession echoes Psalm 51:6, "Against You, You alone, have I sinned," a psalm traditionally attributed to King David after his sin with Bathsheba.

[4] This heading introduces the afternoon prayer service (Mincha) specifically for Tuesday, the third day of the week in the Jewish calendar.

[5] This superscription connects the psalm to the narrative in 1 Samuel 21:10-15, where David fled from Saul to Gath (a Philistine city) and was recognized, leading him to feign madness to escape. This historical context explains the psalm's themes of danger, persecution, and trust in divine deliverance amid hostile surroundings.

[i] This opening uses several terms for pain and sorrow (אוב, נדאב, נכאב) with similar sounds, creating a mournful poetic rhythm that emphasizes the depth of the petitioner's anguish.

[ii] The term זדתי (I have sinned deliberately/willfully) is unusual in prayer contexts, where חטאתי (I have sinned) would be more common. This may reflect the more intense confession appropriate for someone at death's threshold.

[iii] This echoes Psalm 42:4, "My tears have been my food day and night," a common biblical metaphor for extreme grief and repentance.

אֱהַלֵּל דָּבָר בֵּאלֹהִים בָּטַחְתִּי
לֹא אִירָא מַה־יַּעֲשֶׂה בָשָׂר לִי׃
כָּל־הַיּוֹם דִּבְרֵי יְעַצְּבוּ עָלַי
כָּל־מַחְשְׁבֹתָם לָרָע׃ יָגוּרוּ יִצְפִּינוּ
[יִצְפּוֹנוּ] הֵמָּה עֲקֵבַי יִשְׁמֹרוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר
קִוּוּ נַפְשִׁי׃ עַל־אָוֶן פַּלֵּט־לָמוֹ בְּאַף
עַמִּים הוֹרֵד אֱלֹהִים׃ נָדִי סָפַרְתָּה
אָתָּה שִׂימָה דִמְעָתִי בְנֹאדֶךָ הֲלֹא
בְסִפְרָתֶךָ׃ אָז יָשׁוּבוּ אוֹיְבַי אָחוֹר
בְּיוֹם אֶקְרָא זֶה־יָדַעְתִּי כִּי־אֱלֹהִים
לִי׃ בֵּאלֹהִים אֲהַלֵּל דָּבָר בַּיהוָה
אֲהַלֵּל דָּבָר׃ בֵּאלֹהִים בָּטַחְתִּי לֹא
אִירָא מַה־יַּעֲשֶׂה אָדָם לִי׃ עָלַי
אֱלֹהִים נְדָרֶיךָ אֲשַׁלֵּם תּוֹדֹת לָךְ׃
כִּי הִצַּלְתָּ נַפְשִׁי מִמָּוֶת הֲלֹא רַגְלַי
מִדֶּחִי לְהִתְהַלֵּךְ לִפְנֵי אֱלֹהִים
בְּאוֹר הַחַיִּים׃ [i]

You. In God, whose word I praise, in God I trust; I shall not fear. What can flesh do to me? All day long they twist my words; all their thoughts are against me for evil. They stir up strife, they lurk, they watch my steps, as they have waited for my life.[1] Because of their wickedness, cast them out; in anger bring down the peoples, O God.[A] You have kept count of my wanderings; put my tears in Your bottle. Are they not in Your book?[B] Then my enemies will turn back in the day when I call. This I know, that God is for me. In God, whose word I praise, in the LORD, whose word I praise, in God I trust; I shall not fear. What can man do to me? Your vows are upon me, O God; I will render thank offerings to You. For You have delivered my soul from death, indeed, my feet from stumbling, that I may walk before God in the light of life.[2]

[A] Or: "Would they escape by iniquity? In anger cast down the peoples, O God" — The Hebrew phrase פַּלֵּט־לָמוֹ could be interpreted as a rhetorical question about escape rather than a direct plea for their expulsion. This alternate reading preserves the challenging syntax of the original Hebrew while offering a different nuance to the psalmist's expression.

[B] Or: "You have recorded my wanderings; store my tears in Your wineskin—are they not recorded in Your scroll?" — The Hebrew נֹאדֶךָ specifically refers to a wineskin or leather bottle, which has theological significance as it suggests God's careful preservation of the psalmist's suffering. Additionally, 'recorded' better captures the accounting metaphor in the Hebrew text, maintaining the parallel between God's record-keeping of both the psalmist's physical journeys and emotional suffering.

[1] The image of enemies watching, lurking, and waiting parallels the experience of the seriously ill, who may feel stalked by death. This makes the psalm particularly appropriate in Ma'avar Yabok's context of prayers for the sick and dying.

[2] This concluding phrase transforms the psalm from a prayer amid persecution to an expression of hope for continued life in God's presence. For the sick or dying person reciting this in Ma'avar Yabok's context, it could be understood both as hope for physical recovery and as confidence in spiritual life beyond death.

[i] Cf. 1 Samuel 21:10-15 — The historical context illuminates the psalm's themes of persecution and divine deliverance. David's experience of being surrounded by enemies in foreign territory forms the backdrop for this prayer seeking God's protection and expressing confidence in divine deliverance. | Cf. Psalm 56:4/56:11 — This deliberate repetition creates a liturgical structure suitable for communal recitation while emphasizing the psalm's core message of trust in God overcoming fear of human enemies. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this structural feature makes the psalm particularly effective for the sick or dying person who needs to repeatedly affirm trust in God despite threatening circumstances. | Cf. Hebrews 13:6 — While this Christian reference would not have been known to the author of Ma'avar Yabok, it demonstrates how this psalm transcended its original context to become a universal expression of trust in divine protection during times of trial. This universality makes it particularly appropriate for the sick and dying in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences. | Cf. Psalm 116:8-9 — The shared imagery of being delivered from death to walk before God in the light/land of life connects these psalms thematically. This connection would be particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context, where Psalm 56 functions as part of a structured prayer sequence for those facing serious illness or approaching death.

(תורה) הִנֵּה אָנֹכִי שֹׁלֵחַ מַלְאָךְ
990 לְפָנֶיךָ[i] לִשְׁמָרְךָ בַּדָּרֶךְ וְלַהֲבִיאֲךָ
אֶל הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר הֲכִנֹתִי: כִּי אִם
שָׁמֹעַ תִּשְׁמַע בְּקֹלוֹ וְעָשִׂיתָ כֹּל
אֲשֶׁר אֲדַבֵּר וְאָיַבְתִּי אֶת אֹיְבֶיךָ
וְצַרְתִּי אֶת צֹרְרֶיךָ: וַעֲבַדְתֶּם
995 אֵת יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם וּבֵרַךְ אֶת לַחְמְךָ
וְאֶת מֵימֶיךָ וַהֲסִרֹתִי מַחֲלָה
מִקִּרְבֶּךָ:[ii] וַיִּנָּחֶם יְיָ עַל הָרָעָה
אֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר לַעֲשׂוֹת לְעַמּוֹ: וַיֹּאמֶר
פָּנַי יֵלֵכוּ וַהֲנִחֹתִי לָךְ: וְעָשִׂיתָ
1000 בִגְדֵי קֹדֶשׁ לְאַהֲרֹן אָחִיךָ לְכָבוֹד
וּלְתִפְאָרֶת: וַיַּעֲבֹר יְיָ עַל פָּנָיו
וַיִּקְרָא[iii] יְיָ יְיָ אֵל רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן
אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת: נֹצֵר
חֶסֶד לָאֲלָפִים נֹשֵׂא עָוֹן וָפֶשַׁע
1005 וְחַטָּאָה וְנַקֵּה לֹא יְנַקֶּה פֹּקֵד עֲוֹן
אָבוֹת עַל בָּנִים וְעַל בְּנֵי בָנִים עַל
שִׁלֵּשִׁים וְעַל רִבֵּעִים:[iv]

(Torah) Behold, I am sending an angel before you[1] to 1110R
guard you on the way and to bring you to the place
that I have prepared. For if you will indeed obey
his voice and do all that I speak, then I will be an
enemy to your enemies and a foe to your foes. And
you shall serve the LORD your God,[A] and He will 1115R
bless your bread and your water, and I will remove
sickness from your midst.[2] And the LORD relented
concerning the evil that He had spoken of doing to
His people. And He said, "My presence will go with
you, and I will give you rest." And you shall make 1120R
holy garments for Aaron your brother, for glory and
for splendor.[3] And the LORD passed before him and
proclaimed, "LORD, LORD, God, merciful and gra-
cious, slow to anger and abounding in kindness and
truth; preserving kindness for thousands, forgiving 1125R
iniquity and transgression and sin, and cleansing, but
He will not entirely cleanse,[B] visiting the iniquity of
fathers upon children and upon children's children,

[A] Or: "When you worship the LORD your God" — The Hebrew term 'avadetm' (וַעֲבַדְתֶּם) can be translated as either 'serve' or 'worship' in this context. 'Worship' might better reflect the devotional nature of this prayer compilation in Ma'avar Yabok, though 'serve' is more literal and traditional.

[B] Or: "who cleanses, yet does not completely clear [the guilty]" — This phrase from the Thirteen Attributes is notoriously difficult to translate due to its apparent contradiction. This alternate translation makes explicit the implied object (the guilty) and better captures the theological tension between divine forgiveness and justice.

[1] This opening verse establishes a theological framework for the entire prayer section, presenting the idea that divine messengers guide and protect individuals during crucial transitions—whether in life, illness, or death. This parallels Ma'avar Yabok's central metaphor of the soul's journey or 'crossing over.'

[2] This direct promise of healing forms a biblical basis for the prayer's petition. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, such verses were carefully compiled to create prayers with maximum spiritual efficacy, based on the belief that reciting God's own promises of healing back to Him was particularly powerful.

[3] While seemingly out of place in a healing prayer, this reference to Aaron's priestly garments connects to Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic understanding of 'spiritual garments' (levushim) that clothe the soul during and after life. Just as Aaron needed proper garments to approach God in the Temple, the soul requires proper spiritual 'garments' created through good deeds and proper rituals.

[i] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse invoking divine protection through an angel has special significance for the sick or dying person. Kabbalistic tradition interprets the angel as a spiritual guide who escorts the soul through its journey after death, resembling Jacob's angelic escort at the crossing of the Yabok River.

[ii] This promise to remove illness is particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's prayers for healing. It forms part of the biblical justification for petitioning God to heal the sick, based on this explicit divine promise.

[iii] This introduces the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy (י"ג מדות הרחמים), one of the most powerful prayer formulas in Jewish liturgy, especially for seeking forgiveness and healing. The Zohar teaches that these attributes are never recited in vain and have special power to access divine compassion.

[iv] Cf. Exodus 23:20-23 — This opening verse about God sending an angel to guard and guide is from Exodus 23, where God promises protection to the Israelites. In the context of Ma'avar

to the third and fourth generations."[1]

(נביאים) אָנֹכִי אָנֹכִי הוּא
מֹחֶה פְּשָׁעֶיךָ לְמַעֲנִי[i] וְחַטֹּאתֶיךָ
לֹא אֶזְכֹּר: אֲנִי יְיָ וְאֵין עוֹד
זוּלָתִי אֵין אֱלֹהִים אֲאַזֶּרְךָ וְלֹא
יְדַעְתָּנִי:[ii] גֹּאֲלֵנוּ יְיָ צְבָאוֹת
שְׁמוֹ קְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל: לְמַעַן שְׁמִי
אַאֲרִיךְ אַפִּי וּתְהִלָּתִי אֶחֱטָם
לָךְ לְבִלְתִּי הַכְרִיתֶךָ:[iii] הֵן
אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהִים יַעֲזָר לִי מִי הוּא
יַרְשִׁיעֵנִי הֵן אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהִים יַעֲזָר
לִי מִי הוּא יַרְשִׁיעֵנִי הֵן כֻּלָּם
כַּבֶּגֶד יִבְלוּ עָשׁ יֹאכְלֵם:[iv] אָנֹכִי
אָנֹכִי הוּא מְנַחֲמְכֶם מִי אַתְּ
וְתִרְאִי מֵאֱנוֹשׁ יָמוּת וּמִבֶּן אָדָם
חָצִיר יִנָּתֵן:[v] וַיהוָה חָפֵץ דַּכְּאוֹ

(From the Prophets) I, even I, am He who blots out your transgressions[2] for My own sake, and your sins I will not remember. I am the LORD, and there is no other; besides Me there is no God. I will gird you, though you have not known Me. Our Redeemer, the LORD of hosts is His name,[3] the Holy One of Israel. For My name's sake I will defer My anger, and for My praise I will restrain it from you, so that I do not cut you off. Behold, the Lord GOD will help me; who is he who will condemn me? Behold, the Lord GOD will help me; who is he who will condemn me? Indeed they all will grow old like a garment; the moth will eat them up. I, even I, am He who comforts you. Who are you that you should be afraid of a man who will die, and of the son of man who

[1]The prayer ends with the complete formula of the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy, including both the merciful aspects and the warning about intergenerational consequences of sin. This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's theological balance between divine mercy and judgment, presenting illness as potentially serving both punitive and purifying purposes.

[2]The doubling of "I" (אָנֹכִי אָנֹכִי) creates emphatic emphasis on God's personal involvement in forgiveness, highlighting divine agency in the act of pardoning sins.

[3]The divine title "LORD of hosts" (יְיָ צְבָאוֹת) refers to God as commander of heavenly armies, emphasizing divine power in the context of spiritual warfare, which is particularly relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's conceptualization of death as a time when the soul needs protection from negative spiritual forces.

Yabok, this verse functions as a plea for divine protection during illness or the soul's journey after death, comparing the soul's transition to the Israelites' journey through the wilderness. | Cf. Exodus 34:6-7 — The Thirteen Attributes of Mercy form a central liturgical element in Jewish prayers for forgiveness and healing. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses appear in the structured prayer sequences for the sick and dying, invoking God's compassionate nature during times of illness or approaching death. | Cf. Exodus 32:14 — This verse from the golden calf narrative about God relenting from punishment is included to emphasize divine mercy and the potential for God to withdraw illness or suffering when properly petitioned through prayer. | Cf. Exodus 33:14 — This promise of divine presence and rest comes from God's conversation with Moses after the sin of the golden calf. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a petition for divine accompaniment during illness or the soul's journey after death. | Cf. Exodus 28:2 — This verse about Aaron's priestly garments may seem unusual in this prayer context, but in Ma'avar Yabok it likely symbolizes the 'spiritual garments' the soul requires for its journey after death, connecting physical ritual garments to their mystical counterparts.

[i]The phrase "for My own sake" emphasizes that divine forgiveness stems from God's inherent nature and purposes rather than human merit, a theological concept that would be particularly comforting to those anxious about unconfessed sins at the time of death.

[ii]The declaration that God will "gird" (strengthen) a person even when they haven't fully known Him offers hope to those who might fear their religious knowledge or practice has been insufficient.

[iii]The Hebrew verb אֶחֱטָם (echtam) means "I will restrain/muzzle," creating an image of God actively holding back His own judgment for the sake of mercy.

[iv]This metaphor of accusers being consumed like moth-eaten garments would resonate with the kabbalistic concept that harmful spiritual forces (מקטרגים/accusers) pursue the soul at death but can be neutralized through proper prayer.

[v]The comparison of humans to grass (חָצִיר) emphasizes human transience in contrast to divine permanence, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to mortality.

וַיהוָה חָפֵץ דַּכְּאוֹ הֶחֱלִי[i] אִם תָּשִׂים אָשָׁם נַפְשׁוֹ
יִרְאֶה זֶרַע יַאֲרִיךְ יָמִים וְחֵפֶץ יְיָ
1025 בְּיָדוֹ יִצְלָח: מֵעֲמַל נַפְשׁוֹ יִרְאֶה יִשְׂבָּע
[iii] [ii] בְּדַעְתּוֹ יַצְדִּיק צַדִּיק עַבְדִּי לָרַבִּים וַעֲוֹנֹתָם הוּא יִסְבֹּל:

will be made like grass? Yet it pleased the LORD to bruise him; He has put him to grief. When You make his soul an offering for sin, he shall see his seed, he shall prolong his days,[1] and the pleasure of the LORD shall prosper in his hand. For a small moment I have forsaken you, but with great mercies I will gather you.[2] 1145R 1150R

(תהלים) הַשְׁלֵךְ עַל יְיָ יְהָבְךָ[iv] וְהוּא יְכַלְכְּלֶךָ לֹא
יִתֵּן לְעוֹלָם מוֹט לַצַּדִּיק: שָׁאֲפוּ
1030 שׁוֹרְרַי כָּל הַיּוֹם כִּי רַבִּים לְחָמִים

(Psalms) Cast your burden upon the LORD,[3] and He will sustain you; He will never allow the righteous to be moved.[A] My adversaries pant after me all day,[4] for many fight against me from on high.[5] In 1155R

[A] Or: "He will never permit the righteous to be shaken" — The Hebrew מוֹט (mot) carries connotations of being shaken, tottering, or made unstable. This alternate translation emphasizes the sense of stability and steadfastness that God provides, which might be especially relevant for someone experiencing the physical and emotional instability of serious illness.

[1] This phrase from Isaiah's Suffering Servant passage suggests that sacrifice and suffering lead to spiritual reward and continuation, providing theological comfort for the dying by suggesting that physical death is not the end but rather a transition to another form of existence.

[2] The theme of divine gathering (אֲקַבְּצֵךְ) after temporary abandonment connects to Ma'avar Yabok's central metaphor of "crossing over"—suggesting that death represents a temporary separation before eventual reunion with the divine.

[3] The Hebrew יְהָבְךָ (your burden) comes from a root meaning "to give" and refers to whatever weighs heavily on one—whether physical illness, emotional distress, or spiritual concerns. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves as a foundational instruction for the sick person to surrender their suffering to divine care.

[4] The Hebrew שָׁאֲפוּ (they pant/gasp) conveys the image of enemies breathing heavily in pursuit, like predators chasing prey. In the context of illness, this may represent either human adversaries who take advantage of one's weakness or the personification of disease and suffering as pursuing enemies.

[5] The Hebrew מָרוֹם (from on high/heights) creates ambiguity about whether these are powerful

[i] This difficult verse from Isaiah's Suffering Servant passage suggests that suffering can have divine purpose, aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that illness serves a spiritually purifying purpose.

[ii] The concluding promise of gathering with great mercies after a brief abandonment would be particularly meaningful in the context of death, suggesting that the apparent separation is temporary and will be followed by divine reunion.

[iii] Cf. Isaiah 43:25 — This verse emphasizes divine forgiveness as an act of God's sovereign grace rather than human merit, which fits perfectly in a prayer context for those facing illness or death. | Cf. Isaiah 45:5 — This establishes God's absolute power and ability to save, providing theological grounding for the plea being made in the prayer. | Cf. Isaiah 47:4 — Invoking God specifically as Redeemer strengthens the appeal for divine intervention in the context of serious illness or approaching death. | Cf. Isaiah 48:9 — This verse appeals to God's mercy and reputation as reasons for divine forbearance, a key theological concept in prayers for healing and forgiveness. | Cf. Isaiah 50:9 — This repeated verse provides comfort that God will defend the supplicant against accusers (whether human or spiritual), which connects to the kabbalistic concept of negative forces that might interfere with the soul's journey. | Cf. Isaiah 51:12 — This verse provides perspective on mortality, encouraging trust in God rather than fear of mortal threats or death itself. | Cf. Isaiah 53:10 — This verse from the Suffering Servant passage suggests that even suffering can have divine purpose and eventual reward, offering theological comfort to the sick or dying. | Cf. Isaiah 54:7 — This verse offers hope of divine restoration after a period of apparent abandonment, fitting for prayer during illness or approaching death.

[iv] The opening verse uses the Tetragrammaton (יְיָ) in its vocalized form rather than אֱלֹהִים or אֲדֹנָי, which appears in other verses of this compilation. This emphasizes the personal, covenantal relationship with God that forms the basis for the confidence expressed throughout the prayer.

לִי מָרוֹם:[i] יוֹם אִירָא אֲנִי אֵלֶיךָ
אֶבְטָח: נֹדִי סָפַרְתָּה אָתָּה שִׂימָה
דִמְעָתִי בְנֹאדֶךָ[ii] הֲלֹא בְּסִפְרָתֶךָ:
בֵּאלֹהִים אֲהַלֵּל דָּבָר בַּיהוָה
1035 אֲהַלֵּל דָּבָר: בֵּאלֹהִים בָּטַחְתִּי לֹא
אִירָא מַה יַּעֲשֶׂה אָדָם לִי: חָנֵנִי
אֱלֹהִים חָנֵנִי כִּי בְךָ חָסָיָה נַפְשִׁי
וּבְצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ אֶחְסֶה עַד יַעֲבֹר
הַוּוֹת:[iii] אֶקְרָא לֵאלֹהִים עֶלְיוֹן
1040 לָאֵל גֹּמֵר עָלָי: יִשְׁלַח מִשָּׁמַיִם
וְיוֹשִׁיעֵנִי חֵרֵף שֹׁאֲפִי סֶלָה יִשְׁלַח
אֱלֹהִים חַסְדּוֹ וַאֲמִתּוֹ: הַצִּילֵנִי
מֵאֹיְבֵי אֱלֹהַי מִמִּתְקוֹמְמַי תְּשַׂגְּבֵנִי:
הַצִּילֵנִי מִפֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן וּמֵאַנְשֵׁי דָמִים
1045 הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי: אֱלֹהֵי חַסְדִּי יְקַדְּמַנִי
אֱלֹהִים יַרְאֵנִי בְשׁוּרָרָי: יְשַׂמַּח
צַדִּיק כִּי חָזָה נָקָם פְּעָמָיו יִרְחַץ
בְּדַם הָרָשָׁע:[iv] וְאֹמַר אָשִׁיר עֻזֶּךָ
וַאֲרַנֵּן לַבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ כִּי הָיִיתָ
1050 מִשְׂגָּב לִי וּמָנוֹס בְּיוֹם צַר לִי: עֻזִּי

the day when I am afraid, I will trust in You. You have recorded my wanderings; put my tears into Your bottle[A]—are they not in Your book? In God I will praise His word, in the LORD I will praise His word. In God I have put my trust; I will not fear what man 1160R
can do to me. Be gracious to me, O God, be gracious to me, for my soul takes refuge in You; and in the shadow of Your wings I will take shelter until the destruction passes by.[B] I will cry to God Most High, to God who accomplishes all things for me. He will 1165R
send from heaven and save me; He reproaches those who trample upon me.[1] Selah.[2] God will send forth His lovingkindness and His truth. Deliver me from my enemies, O my God; set me securely on high away from those who rise up against me. Deliver 1170R
me from the workers of iniquity, and save me from bloodthirsty men. My God of lovingkindness will meet me; God will let me look upon my adversaries. Let the righteous rejoice for he has seen vengeance; he will wash his feet in the blood of the wicked.[3] But 1175R

[A] Or: "store my tears in Your flask" — The Hebrew נאד (nod) refers specifically to a skin bottle or flask used for storing liquids. This alternate translation provides a slightly more precise image of the container while maintaining the powerful metaphor of God preserving each tear as precious.

[B] Or: "until the calamities have passed" — The Hebrew הַוּוֹת (havot) is plural and refers to multiple destructions or calamities. This alternate translation captures the plural form and connects to Ma'avar Yabok's view of illness as comprising multiple forms of suffering that will eventually pass.

human adversaries or spiritual forces. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok's kabbalistic framework, this could suggest negative spiritual entities that afflict the sick from celestial realms.

[1] The Hebrew חֵרֵף שֹׁאֲפִי (He reproaches my pursuers/those who pant after me) suggests divine rebuke of those causing suffering. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this might refer to God addressing both human enemies and spiritual forces of illness.

[2] The Hebrew term סֶלָה (Selah) appears twice in this compilation, possibly serving as a liturgical instruction for pause or musical interlude. In the context of prayers for the sick, these pauses might provide moments for contemplation or for the sick person to rest during the recitation.

[3] This violent imagery comes from ancient Near Eastern battle contexts where victors would wade

[i] The word "מָרוֹם" (from on high) could be interpreted in two ways: either referring to enemies fighting from an advantageous position, or suggesting that these enemies have some form of celestial or spiritual power. In the context of prayers for the sick in Ma'avar Yabok, this might allude to harmful spiritual forces that afflict the ill person.

[ii] The powerful image of God collecting tears in a bottle (נאד—a skin container for liquids) suggests that no suffering goes unnoticed by God. This metaphor would be particularly poignant in the context of prayers for the sick, where physical suffering produces literal tears that are precious to God.

[iii] The imagery of seeking refuge "under the shadow of Your wings" (בְּצֵל כְּנָפֶיךָ) evokes both the cherubim wings over the Ark of the Covenant and the protective behavior of a mother bird. This maternal imagery of divine protection appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok and was considered particularly appropriate for comforting the sick and dying.

[iv] This vivid and violent imagery of washing feet in the blood of the wicked comes from Psalm 58:10. In the context of prayers for the sick, this might be understood metaphorically as the triumph of righteousness over the forces of illness and suffering, rather than literal vengeance against human enemies.

אֵלֶיךָ אֲזַמְּרָה אֱלֹהִים מִשְׂגַּבִּי אֱלֹהֵי
חַסְדִּי: בֵּאלֹהִים נַעֲשֶׂה חָיִל וְהוּא
יָבוּס צָרֵינוּ: שִׂמְאָה אֱלֹהִים רַנָּתִי
הַקְשִׁיבָה תְּפִלָּתִי: אַךְ אֶל אֱלֹהִים
1055 דּוֹמִיָּה נַפְשִׁי מִמֶּנּוּ יְשׁוּעָתִי: אַךְ
הוּא צוּרִי וְיִשׁוּעָתִי מִשְׂגַּבִּי לֹא
אֶמּוֹט רַבָּה: אַךְ לֵאלֹהִים דּוֹמִי
נַפְשִׁי כִּי מִמֶּנּוּ תִקְוָתִי: אַךְ הוּא
צוּרִי וְיִשׁוּעָתִי מִשְׂגַּבִּי לֹא אֶמּוֹט:
1060 עַל אֱלֹהִים יִשְׁעִי וּכְבוֹדִי צוּר עֻזִּי
מַחְסִי בֵּאלֹהִים: אֱלֹהִים אֵלִי אַתָּה
אֲשַׁחֲרֶךָּ צָמְאָה לְךָ נַפְשִׁי כָּמַהּ
לְךָ בְשָׂרִי בְּאֶרֶץ צִיָּה וְעָיֵף בְּלִי
מָיִם: כִּי טוֹב חַסְדְּךָ מֵחַיִּים שְׂפָתַי
1065 יְשַׁבְּחוּנֶךָּ: כֵּן אֲבָרֶכְךָ בְחַיָּי בְּשִׁמְךָ
אֶשָּׂא כַפָּי: שְׂמַע אֱלֹהִים קוֹלִי
בְשִׂיחִי מִפַּחַד אוֹיֵב תִּצֹּר חַיָּי:
תַּסְתִּירֵנִי מִסּוֹד מְרֵעִים מֵרִגְשַׁת
פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן: הֵרַכְּבְתָּ אֱנוֹשׁ לְרֹאשֵׁנוּ
1070 בָּאנוּ בָאֵשׁ וּבַמָּיִם וַתּוֹצִיאֵנוּ
לָרְוָיָה:[i] יִשְׂמַח צַדִּיק בַּיהוָה
וְחָסָה בוֹ וְיִתְהַלְלוּ כָּל יִשְׁרֵי
לֵב: שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּה עֲדֶיךָ כָּל בָּשָׂר
יָבֹאוּ: אָכֵן שָׁמַע אֱלֹהִים הִקְשִׁיב
1075 בְּקוֹל תְּפִלָּתִי: בָּרוּךְ אֱלֹהִים אֲשֶׁר
לֹא הֵסִיר תְּפִלָּתִי וְחַסְדּוֹ מֵאִתִּי:
אֱלֹהִים יְחָנֵּנוּ וִיבָרְכֵנוּ יָאֵר פָּנָיו
אִתָּנוּ סֶלָה:[iii ii]

I will sing of Your strength; yes, I will joyfully sing of Your lovingkindness in the morning, for You have been my stronghold and a refuge in the day of my distress. O my strength, to You I will sing praises; for God is my stronghold, the God of my lovingkindness. 1180R
Through God we shall do valiantly, and it is He who will trample our adversaries. Hear my cry, O God; give attention to my prayer. My soul waits in silence for God alone; from Him comes my salvation. He alone is my rock and my salvation, my stronghold; I 1185R
shall not be greatly moved. My soul, wait in silence for God alone, for my hope is from Him. He alone is my rock and my salvation, my stronghold; I shall not be moved. On God rests my salvation and my glory; the rock of my strength, my refuge is in God. O God, 1190R
You are my God; I shall seek You earnestly; my soul thirsts for You, my flesh yearns for You,[1] in a dry and weary land where there is no water. Because Your lovingkindness is better than life, my lips will praise You. So I will bless You as long as I live; I will lift 1195R
up my hands in Your name. Hear my voice, O God, in my meditation; preserve my life from dread of the enemy. Hide me from the secret counsel of evildoers, from the tumult of those who do iniquity. You have placed men over our heads; we went through 1200R
fire and through water, yet You brought us out to abundance.[A] The righteous will rejoice in the LORD and take refuge in Him, and all the upright in heart

[A] Or: "You made us pass through fire and water, then led us out to overflowing relief" — This alternate translation emphasizes God's agency in both the suffering ("You made us pass") and the deliverance, while rendering לָרְוָיָה (revayah) as "overflowing relief" to capture both the abundant and refreshing nature of the deliverance, especially apt in the context of prayers for the sick.

through the blood of vanquished enemies. In the context of prayers for the sick, this serves as a metaphor for complete triumph over forces of suffering and illness rather than literal violence.

[1] The Hebrew כָּמַהּ לְךָ בְשָׂרִי (my flesh yearns for You) is significant because it emphasizes that not just the spirit but the physical body itself longs for God. For the sick person whose flesh is failing, this validates physical suffering as a spiritual experience where even bodily pain can become a form of yearning for divine presence.

[i] The phrase "we went through fire and through water" uses powerful elemental imagery to describe extreme suffering, while "You brought us out to abundance" (לָרְוָיָה—literally "to saturation/overflowing") provides the counterpoint of divine deliverance. This creates a narrative arc of suffering followed by rescue that would be particularly meaningful for the sick.

[ii] The prayer concludes with words from the Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24-26), specifically "may He make His face shine upon us." This creates a powerful closing that invokes divine radiance and favor, appropriate for ending a prayer sequence for healing and protection.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 55:22 — This opening verse establishes the theme of divine trust and protection that runs throughout this prayer compilation. It appears in the original as Psalm 55:23 in the Hebrew numbering, and serves as an anchor for the entire prayer sequence. | Cf. Psalm 56-59 — Many verses in this compilation come from consecutive Psalms (56-59), suggesting a deliberate selection of passages from David's psalms of distress and deliverance when he was pursued by enemies.

will glory. O You who hear prayer, to You all flesh will come. Surely God has heard; He has given heed to the voice of my prayer. Blessed be God, who has not turned away my prayer nor His lovingkindness from me. God be gracious to us and bless us, and cause His face to shine upon us. Selah. 1205R

(כתובים) לִהְיוֹת בַּיהוָה מִבְטַחֶךָ (From Writings) That your trust may be in the LORD,[1] I have made them known to you this day, even to you. Have I not written to you two things?[2] Remove falsehood and lying far from me; give me neither poverty nor riches, feed me with my allotted bread.[3] Naked I came from my mother's womb, and naked shall I return there. The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away;[4] blessed be the name of the LORD. For now I would lie 1210R 1215R

1080 הוֹדַעְתִּיךָ הַיּוֹם אַף אָתָּה:[i] שְׁתַּיִם
שָׁאַלְתִּי מֵאִתָּךְ אַל תִּמְנַע מִמֶּנִּי
בְּטֶרֶם אָמוּת:[ii] שָׁוְא וּדְבַר כָּזָב
הַרְחֵק מִמֶּנִּי רֵאשׁ וְעֹשֶׁר אַל תִּתֶּן לִי
הַטְרִיפֵנִי לֶחֶם חֻקִּי:[iii] עָרֹם יָצָאתִי
1085 מִבֶּטֶן אִמִּי וְעָרֹם אָשׁוּב שָׁמָּה:[iv] יְיָ
נָתַן וַיהוָה לָקָח יְהִי שֵׁם יְיָ
מְבֹרָךְ:[v] כִּי עַתָּה שָׁכַבְתִּי וְאִשְׁקוֹט

[1]This compilation of biblical verses emphasizes acceptance of divine providence, mortality, and the spiritual benefit of suffering—all central themes in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death and dying.

[2]The text omits Proverbs 30:7's ending, which specifies "excellent things in counsels and knowledge," focusing instead on the request that follows, creating a more direct personal plea.

[3]The Hebrew term 'lechem chuki' (allotted bread) suggests not merely physical sustenance but also one's divinely ordained portion in life, a concept that connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on accepting one's destiny.

[4]This verse from Job forms the foundation for Jewish responses to death, acknowledging divine sovereignty while maintaining faith. It appears frequently in funeral liturgy and deathbed rituals.

These psalms share themes of divine protection amid persecution. | Cf. Psalm 61-63 — The compilation continues with verses from Psalms 61-63, which focus on themes of divine refuge, thirst for God, and confidence in divine deliverance. The compiler has carefully selected passages that progress from expressions of distress to declarations of trust. | Cf. Psalm 64 — The verses about hiding from evil counsel and the tumult of evildoers come from Psalm 64, continuing the theme of divine protection against those who plot harm. | Cf. Psalm 66:12 — This verse serves as a powerful metaphor for the sick person's experience of suffering (fire and water) followed by divine deliverance to abundance. It provides hope that current afflictions will lead to eventual relief. | Cf. Psalm 64:10, 65:2-3, 66:20, 67:2 — The compilation concludes with verses that express confidence in divine response to prayer, gratitude for God's attentiveness, and a request for blessing. These create a satisfying resolution to the prayer sequence, moving from distress to hope. | Cf. Isaiah 38 — Though not directly quoted, the themes of this compilation echo King Hezekiah's prayer during his illness (Isaiah 38), particularly the recording of tears and the divine response to prayer. This connection would be meaningful in the context of prayers for the sick. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's YaBOK verses — This compilation appears to be part of Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer sequences for the sick and dying. It follows the book's pattern of creating therapeutic spiritual progressions through carefully selected biblical verses that move from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation.

[i]This verse is from Proverbs 22:19, though the collection continues with verses from different biblical books, assembled as a prayer of spiritual preparation.

[ii]From Proverbs 30:7, where Agur son of Jakeh asks for two things before death, creating a powerful contemplation of mortality appropriate for Ma'avar Yabok's focus.

[iii]From Proverbs 30:8, requesting the middle path between poverty and wealth, which aligns with the book's emphasis on accepting divine providence in life and death.

[iv]From Job 1:21, a verse often associated with death and the acceptance of divine judgment, central to Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework.

[v]Continues from Job 1:21, Job's famous declaration of acceptance of both blessing and loss, which is particularly appropriate in a prayer sequence focused on preparation for death.

שָׁנַתִּי אָז נָוחַ לִי: [i] אוּלָם אֲנִי
אֶדְרֹשׁ אֶל אֵל וְאֶל אֱלֹהִים אָשִׂים
1090 דִּבְרָתִי: [ii] עֹשֶׂה גְדֹלוֹת וְאֵין חֵקֶר
נִפְלָאוֹת עַד אֵין מִסְפָּר: [iii] מַפֵּר
מַחְשְׁבוֹת עֲרוּמִים וְלֹא תַעֲשֶׂינָה
יְדֵיהֶם תּוּשִׁיָּה: [iv] וַתְּהִי לַדַּל תִּקְוָה
וְעַלְתָה קָפְצָה פִּיהָ: [v] הִנֵּה אַשְׁרֵי
1095 אֱנוֹשׁ יוֹכִיחֶנּוּ אֱלוֹהַּ וּמוּסַר שַׁדַּי אַל
תִּמְאָס: [vi] כִּי הוּא יַכְאִיב וְיַחֲבֹשׁ
יִמְחַץ וְיָדָיו תִּרְפֶּינָה: [vii] [viii]

down and be quiet; I would sleep, then I would have rest.[A] But as for me, I will seek God, and 1220R
to God I will direct my plea. He does great things beyond comprehension, wonders without number. He frustrates the plans of the crafty, so that their hands achieve no success. So the poor have hope, and injustice shuts its mouth.[B] Behold, happy is the 1225R
man whom God corrects;[1] therefore do not despise the chastening of the Almighty. For He wounds, but He binds up; He strikes, but His hands heal.[2]

צְפֵה עָשְׁקִי [ix] וְאַל תֶּפֶן

Behold my oppression and do not regard my stub-

[A] Or: "For now I would have lain down and been at peace; I would have slept and found rest" — This alternative uses a conditional past tense to better capture the hypothetical nature of Job's statement in its original context, though in Ma'avar Yabok's context, either translation works as a meditation on death as peaceful rest.

[B] Or: "So there is hope for the destitute, and iniquity stops its mouth" — This alternative translation emphasizes the spiritual condition of being destitute rather than merely economic poverty, and uses 'iniquity' which carries stronger moral connotations than 'injustice', potentially better reflecting the theological context of Ma'avar Yabok.

[1] This theological perspective on suffering as divine correction rather than punishment is fundamental to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness and death, suggesting that even painful experiences serve a spiritual purpose.

[2] This concluding verse offers comfort by affirming that divine wounding is ultimately for healing, echoing Ma'avar Yabok's view that physical death leads to spiritual renewal and eternal life.

[i] From Job 3:13, where Job speaks of death as rest, a theme that connects to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of death as peaceful transition rather than merely an end.

[ii] From Job 5:8, a declaration of turning to God in times of trouble, creating a contrast with Job's earlier despair and aligning with the book's emphasis on maintaining faith even during suffering.

[iii] From Job 5:9, describing God's incomprehensible wonders, a theme that emerges throughout Ma'avar Yabok in its discussion of divine providence and the mysteries of life and death.

[iv] From Job 5:12, describing God's frustration of the plans of the crafty, which connects to the book's theme that human plans are ultimately subject to divine will.

[v] From Job 5:16, describing how God's intervention gives hope to the poor and silences injustice, creating a sense of divine justice that extends beyond this world.

[vi] From Job 5:17, presenting the theological view that divine correction is a blessing rather than a curse, aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of suffering as spiritually beneficial.

[vii] From Job 5:18, describing God as both wounder and healer, which connects to the book's understanding of illness and death as part of a divine process that ultimately leads to healing in a spiritual sense.

[viii] Cf. Proverbs 22:19-21 — Sets the tone of wisdom and trust in divine providence, essential for preparing oneself spiritually for death. | Cf. Proverbs 30:7-9 — Establishes the prayer's focus on preparation for death, avoiding both spiritual and material excess, seeking only what is necessary for the soul's journey. | Cf. Job 1:21 — This pivotal verse in Jewish understanding of death is central to Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, emphasizing that we return to our Creator as we came—with nothing but our essential self. | Cf. Job 3:13 — While originally part of Job's complaint, in this context the verse is repurposed to present death as peaceful rest rather than annihilation, aligning with the book's focus on death as transition rather than end. | Cf. Job 5:8-18 — Though from Eliphaz (whose theology the book of Job ultimately critiques), these verses are repurposed here to present a positive view of divine chastisement as ultimately beneficial, supporting Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of illness and death as spiritually purposeful.

[ix] The verb 'צְפֵה' (behold/observe) creates a deliberate contrast with 'וְאַל תֶּפֶן' (do not regard/turn to) in the same line, emphasizing the plea for God to selectively see the person's suffering but not their failings.

לְקָשְׁיִי.[i] רְאֵה עָנְיִי וְאַל תִּרְאֶה
עֲוֹנִי.[ii] קְשׁוֹב נָא לַהֲגִיגִי[iii] אֵל
רְצֵנִי. וְשִׂיחִי לְךָ בְּקָרְאִי תַּעֲנֵנִי:

bornness.[1] See my affliction and do not see my iniquity. Please listen to my meditation, God, accept me.[2] And when I call to You with my prayer, answer me.[3]

סדר יום רביעי

Order of Wednesday

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[iv] ואחר כך יאמר זה[v][vi]

One should recite[4] the verses of "Ana Hashem" and afterward recite this[5]

(תהלים נז) לַמְנַצֵּחַ אַל־תַּשְׁחֵת לְדָוִד מִכְתָּם[vii] בְּבָרְחוֹ

(Psalm 57) For the choirmaster. To the tune of "Do Not Destroy." A miktam of David,[6] when he fled

[1]The translation preserves the parallel structure of the Hebrew, where the first two lines each contain a positive request ('behold/see') followed by a negative one ('do not regard/see'). This pattern creates a poetic plea for selective divine attention.

[2]The Hebrew 'אֵל רְצֵנִי' is rendered as 'God, accept me,' though it could also be translated as 'God, favor me' or 'God, be pleased with me.' The concept involves divine acceptance or approval of the supplicant.

[3]The prayer concludes with the straightforward request for divine response ('תַּעֲנֵנִי'), shifting from asking God to perceive and accept to actively respond, creating a progression from divine awareness to divine action.

[4]I've chosen to translate the impersonal third-person singular verb "יאמר" (yomar) as "One should recite" rather than "He should recite" to maintain the instructional tone while avoiding gender specificity, as this is clearly a ritual instruction for anyone performing this prayer sequence.

[5]The demonstrative "זה" (zeh/"this") refers to what follows in the text, namely Psalm 57, which would appear immediately after this instruction in the original text of Ma'avar Yabok.

[6]The term "miktam" appears in the titles of several psalms (16, 56-60) and may refer to a specific literary or musical form. While its exact meaning is uncertain, some scholars suggest it derives from a root meaning "to cover" or "to hide," perhaps indicating a psalm with hidden depths or mystical significance.

[i]The term 'קְשָׁיִי' (my stubbornness/hardness) acknowledges the supplicant's own role in their spiritual condition, similar to the biblical concept of 'stiff-necked people' (עַם קְשֵׁה עֹרֶף) often used to describe Israel's resistance to divine will.

[ii]This line creates a parallel structure to the first line, again asking God to be selective in what He perceives—to see suffering but not sin. This rhetorical structure emphasizes the supplicant's vulnerability and dependence on divine mercy.

[iii]The term 'הֲגִיגִי' (my meditation/murmuring) suggests deep, sometimes inarticulate thoughts or prayers, indicating that the supplicant is asking God to perceive not just formal prayers but inner spiritual struggles.

[iv]This refers to a set of verses beginning with "Ana Hashem" (Please, O Lord) that appear as a standard opening formula in each of the eight prayer sequences (sedarim) in Ma'avar Yabok. These verses were to be recited before the specific psalms for each day.

[v]This is a liturgical instruction indicating that after reciting the opening "Ana Hashem" verses, one should continue with the specific prayer text that follows (in this case, Psalm 57, which appears in the Wednesday prayer sequence).

[vi]Cf. Psalm 57 — This instruction indicates the proper liturgical order of the Wednesday prayer, directing the reader to first recite the standard opening "Ana Hashem" verses before proceeding to Psalm 57. This reflects the book's systematic approach to organizing prayers for each day of the week following a consistent structure. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok prayer structure — This brief instruction reflects the highly structured nature of Ma'avar Yabok's prayer system, where specific formulaic elements appear in a prescribed order. The standardized opening 'Ana Hashem' verses create continuity across the different daily prayer sequences, while each day has its own designated psalms and scriptural verses.

[vii]The term "miktam" is a musical or literary designation that appears in the headings of several psalms. Its exact meaning is uncertain, though some scholars suggest it refers to an inscription or a golden poem.

מִפְּנֵי־שָׁאוּל בַּמְּעָרָה׃ חָנֵּנִי
אֱלֹהִים חָנֵּנִי כִּי בְךָ חָסְיָה נַפְשִׁי
וּבְצֵל־כְּנָפֶיךָ אֶחְסֶה[ii] עַד יַעֲבֹר
הַוּוֹת[iii]׃ אֶקְרָא לֵאלֹהִים עֶלְיוֹן
לָאֵל גֹּמֵר עָלָי[iv]׃ יִשְׁלַח מִשָּׁמַיִם
וְיוֹשִׁיעֵנִי חֵרֵף שֹׁאֲפִי[v] סֶלָה
יִשְׁלַח אֱלֹהִים חַסְדּוֹ וַאֲמִתּוֹ׃
נַפְשִׁי בְּתוֹךְ לְבָאִם[vi] אֶשְׁכְּבָה
לְהָטִּים[vii] בְּנֵי־אָדָם שִׁנֵּיהֶם חֲנִית
וְחִצִּים וּלְשׁוֹנָם חֶרֶב חַדָּה[viii]׃
רוּמָה עַל־הַשָּׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים עַל
כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ׃ רֶשֶׁת הֵכִינוּ
לִפְעָמַי כָּפַף נַפְשִׁי כָּרוּ לְפָנַי שִׁיחָה
נָפְלוּ בְתוֹכָהּ סֶלָה׃ נָכוֹן לִבִּי
אֱלֹהִים נָכוֹן לִבִּי אָשִׁירָה וַאֲזַמֵּרָה׃
עוּרָה כְבוֹדִי עוּרָה הַנֵּבֶל וְכִנּוֹר

from Saul into the cave. Be gracious to me, O God, be gracious to me, for in You my soul takes refuge; 1240R
in the shadow of Your wings I will take shelter[A] until
the calamities pass by. I will cry to God Most High,
to God who fulfills His purpose for me.[B] He will
send from heaven and save me; He will put to shame
those who trample on me. Selah. God will send 1245R
forth His steadfast love and His truth. My soul is
among lions; I must lie down amid fiery beasts[C]—the
children of men, whose teeth are spears and arrows,
and whose tongue is a sharp sword. Be exalted above
the heavens, O God; let Your glory be over all the 1250R
earth. They prepared a net for my steps;[1] my soul
was bowed down. They dug a pit before me, but they
fell into it themselves. Selah. My heart is steadfast,
O God, my heart is steadfast! I will sing and make

[A] Or: "beneath the shelter of Your wings I will seek refuge" — This alternate emphasizes the protective aspect of the metaphor with 'shelter' and uses 'beneath' to strengthen the spatial imagery, which aligns with kabbalistic interpretations of divine protection in Ma'avar Yabok.

[B] Or: "to God who completes what concerns me" — This alternate is more literal and reflects the Hebrew more directly. In the context of prayers for the dying in Ma'avar Yabok, this could evoke the completion of one's life journey.

[C] Or: "My soul is in the midst of lions; I lie among those who breathe fire" — This alternate conveys the intensity of 'לְהָטִּים' (fiery/blazing ones) with the vivid image of fire-breathing enemies, which could be interpreted in Ma'avar Yabok's context as spiritual accusers or harmful forces threatening the soul.

[1] The imagery of enemies setting traps recalls other psalms in Ma'avar Yabok's liturgical sequences. In the context of prayers for the sick, these metaphorical traps could represent both physical illness and spiritual obstacles threatening the soul.

[i] This likely refers to either the incident in the cave of Adullam (1 Samuel 22) or the cave of En-gedi (1 Samuel 24) when David was fleeing from King Saul.

[ii] The metaphor of taking refuge "under God's wings" appears frequently in the psalms and evokes the image of a mother bird sheltering her young, symbolizing divine protection. This imagery is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, where it represents the soul finding protection under the Divine Presence (Shekhinah), especially during illness or approaching death.

[iii] This term refers to calamities, destructions, or disasters. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this passage would be understood as referring to the trials of illness and impending death that will eventually pass.

[iv] This phrase can be translated as "to God who fulfills His purpose for me" or "to God who completes [what concerns] me." In the context of deathbed prayers, this would be understood as God completing one's life journey and spiritual purpose.

[v] This difficult phrase could be translated as "He rebukes those who trample on me" or "He puts to shame those who pant after me." In mystical interpretations, these enemies could represent not just human adversaries but also the spiritual forces or accusers that threaten the soul.

[vi] The Hebrew term "לְבָאִם" (lions) is used metaphorically to represent fierce enemies. In kabbalistic thought, such as that found in Ma'avar Yabok, these could also represent spiritual adversaries or harmful forces that threaten the soul during illness or at death.

[vii] The term "לְהָטִּים" (blazing or fiery ones) intensifies the dangerous imagery. These enemies are not just lions but flaming or fiery beasts, suggesting destructive power.

[viii] This vivid metaphor depicting enemies with weapon-like teeth and sword-like tongues emphasizes the deadly threat of slander and verbal attacks. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this could be connected to the concept of spiritual accusers or prosecutors in the heavenly court.

אָעִירָה שָׁחַר[i]: אוּרִי כָּבוֹד עוּרָה נֵבֶל וְכִנּוֹר
אָדֶנְיָ אֲזַמֶּרְךָ בַּל־אֻמִּים: כִּי־גָדֹל
עַד־שָׁמַיִם חַסְדֶּךָ וְעַד־שְׁחָקִים
אֲמִתֶּךָ: רוּמָה עַל־שָׁמַיִם אֱלֹהִים
עַל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ כְּבוֹדֶךָ.[ii][iii]

melody! Awake, my glory![A] Awake, O harp and lyre! 1255R
I will awaken the dawn.[B] I will praise You among
the peoples, O Lord; I will sing praises to You among
the nations. For Your steadfast love is great to the
heavens,[1] and Your truth to the clouds. Be exalted
above the heavens, O God; let Your glory be over all 1260R
the earth.

(תורה) וְשָׁחַט אֹתוֹ עַל יֶרֶךְ
הַמִּזְבֵּחַ צָפֹנָה לִפְנֵי יְיָ[iv] וְזָרְקוּ בְּנֵי
אַהֲרֹן הַכֹּהֲנִים אֶת דָּמוֹ עַל הַמִּזְבֵּחַ
סָבִיב: וְאֵת מִשְׁחַת אַהֲרֹן וּמִשְׁחַת

(Torah) And he shall slaughter it on the side of the
altar[C] northward before the LORD;[2] and Aaron's
sons, the priests, shall dash its blood against the
altar round about. This is the anointing portion 1265R

[A] Or: "Awake, my soul!" — Since 'כְּבוֹדִי' (my glory) can refer to the soul or inner self in Hebrew poetics, this alternate makes explicit what is implicit in the original, which would resonate with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the soul's journey.

[B] Or: "I will rouse the morning light" — This alternate emphasizes the active role of the psalmist in bringing forth light, which connects thematically to Ma'avar Yabok's reference to the prayer society 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn).

[C] Or: "at the flank of the altar" — The term 'yerekh' literally means 'thigh' or 'flank' and is used metaphorically to refer to the side of the altar. This more literal translation might better preserve the anatomical metaphor in the original Hebrew.

[1] The Hebrew terms translated as "steadfast love" (חֶסֶד/chesed) and "truth" (אֱמֶת/emet) are foundational theological concepts in Jewish thought. Chesed represents God's covenant faithfulness and loving-kindness, while emet represents God's absolute reliability and truthfulness. These divine attributes are frequently invoked in Ma'avar Yabok's prayers for divine mercy toward the sick and dying.

[2] This collection of Torah verses begins with sacrificial laws, specifically mentioning the requirement that certain offerings be slaughtered on the north side of the altar, which had mystical significance in Jewish tradition.

[i] The phrase "I will awaken the dawn" suggests that the psalmist's praise precedes and summons the morning light. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connection to dawn would resonate with the book's reference to the prayer society 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn).

[ii] This verse serves as both the opening and closing refrain of the psalm, creating a frame that emphasizes God's transcendence and immanence—exalted above heaven yet with glory covering the earth. This balance of divine attributes would be significant in kabbalistic thought.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 91 — Psalm 91 appears frequently in Ma'avar Yabok, particularly as a protective prayer to be recited for the sick and dying. The shared imagery of refuge and divine protection links these psalms thematically, making Psalm 57 an appropriate addition to the liturgical sequences for those facing illness or death. | Cf. Psalm 17 — Psalm 17 also appears in Ma'avar Yabok's 'Seder' section. The recurring wing imagery across multiple psalms in this collection reinforces the central metaphor of divine protection for the vulnerable soul, especially appropriate for the sick and dying. | Cf. Psalm 36 — The recurring imagery of divine protection and expansive heavenly love creates a consistent theological framework across the psalms selected for Ma'avar Yabok, emphasizing God's encompassing care for those in distress. | Cf. 1 Samuel 24 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this allusion to David's mercy toward Saul despite being in mortal danger would suggest a spiritual lesson about forgiveness and trust in divine justice even when facing one's greatest fears. | Cf. Genesis 32 — This psalm's themes of divine protection during mortal danger parallel Jacob's experience at the Jabbok (Yabok) crossing, the central metaphor of Ma'avar Yabok. Both involve facing deadly threats, divine intervention, and ultimate deliverance and transformation.

[iv] This is from Leviticus 1:11, describing the procedure for sacrificing an animal offering. The slaughtering had to be done on the northern side of the altar.

בָּנָיו[i] מֵאִשֵּׁי יְיָ בְּיוֹם הַקְרִיב אֹתָם
לְכַהֵן לַיְיָ: וַיִּצֹק מִשֶּׁמֶן הַמִּשְׁחָה עַל
רֹאשׁ אַהֲרֹן[ii] וַיִּמְשַׁח אֹתוֹ לְקַדְּשׁוֹ:
כִּי בְיוֹם הַזֶּה יְכַפֵּר עֲלֵיכֶם לְטַהֵר
אֶתְכֶם[iii] מִכֹּל חַטֹּאתֵיכֶם לִפְנֵי
יְיָ תִּטְהָרוּ: וְנָתְנָה הָאָרֶץ פִּרְיָהּ
וַאֲכַלְתֶּם לָשֹׂבַע[iv] וִישַׁבְתֶּם לָבֶטַח
עָלֶיהָ: וּרְדַפְתֶּם אֶת אֹיְבֵיכֶם
וְנָפְלוּ לִפְנֵיכֶם לֶחָרֶב:[v] וּפָנִיתִי
אֲלֵיכֶם וְהִפְרֵיתִי אֶתְכֶם וְהִרְבֵּיתִי
אֶתְכֶם[vi] וַהֲקִימֹתִי אֶת בְּרִיתִי
אִתְּכֶם: כֹּה תְבָרְכוּ אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
[viii vii]אָמוֹר לָהֶם:

of Aaron[A] and the anointing portion of his sons, from the offerings by fire to the LORD, on the day when he presented them to minister as priests to the LORD.[1] And he poured of the anointing oil upon Aaron's head, and anointed him to sanctify him. 1270R
For on this day shall atonement be made for you, to cleanse you; from all your sins shall you be clean before the LORD.[2] And the land shall yield her fruit, and you shall eat your fill, and dwell in safety upon it.[B] And you shall chase your enemies, and they 1275R
shall fall before you by the sword. And I will turn to you, and make you fruitful, and multiply you,[3] and establish My covenant with you. Thus shall you bless the children of Israel, saying to them:[4]

(נביאים[ix]) דְּרָכָיו רָאִיתִי I have seen his ways, but I will heal him; I will guide 1280R

[A]Or: "the consecrated portion of Aaron" — While 'anointing portion' is accurate, 'consecrated portion' might better convey the purpose of this allocation, emphasizing its sacred status rather than just the method of designation.

[B]Or: "and dwell securely upon it" — 'Securely' might better capture the Hebrew 'lavetach' which implies not just physical safety but a sense of confidence and freedom from worry.

[1]The text moves from sacrifice to priestly consecration, establishing a progression from ritual offering to sanctification through anointing.

[2]The theme transitions to purification and atonement, connecting priestly ritual to spiritual cleansing of the community.

[3]The verses then shift to divine promises of blessing, creating a thematic progression from sacrifice to consecration to purification to reward.

[4]The section concludes with the introduction to the Priestly Blessing, suggesting that the entire collection serves as preparation for this culminating blessing. This creates a structure where human ritual (sacrifice) leads to divine response (blessing).

[i]From Leviticus 7:35, referring to the portion designated for Aaron and his sons from the sacrificial offerings.

[ii]From Leviticus 8:12, describing Aaron's consecration as High Priest through anointing with sacred oil.

[iii]From Leviticus 16:30, referring to Yom Kippur (Day of Atonement), when purification from sins is achieved.

[iv]From Leviticus 26:4-5, describing divine blessings of agricultural abundance and security that follow observance of God's commandments.

[v]From Leviticus 26:7, continuing the promises of divine blessing, here specifically victory over enemies.

[vi]From Leviticus 26:9, describing God's promise to make Israel fruitful and numerous.

[vii]From Numbers 6:23, the introduction to the Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim).

[viii]Cf. Leviticus 1:11 — This is the beginning of a sequence of Torah verses related to priestly service and sacrifice. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would invoke the protective power of sacred text while connecting the sick person's suffering to Temple sacrifices. | Cf. Leviticus 16:30 — The inclusion of this verse about cleansing from sin links physical illness with spiritual purification, suggesting that the prayer is intended to achieve both physical and spiritual healing. | Cf. Leviticus 26:4-9 — These verses promising abundance, security, and divine favor create a progression from atonement to blessing, suggesting that the sick person's healing will lead to renewed prosperity and divine protection. | Cf. Numbers 6:23 — Ending with the introduction to the Priestly Blessing creates a powerful conclusion, as this blessing was considered particularly potent for healing and protection. The entire sequence thus moves from sacrifice to consecration to atonement to blessing.

[ix]This heading indicates that the following verses are taken from the Prophetic books (Nevi'im) of the Hebrew Bible, specifically from Isaiah and Jeremiah.

וְאֶרְפָּאֵהוּ וְאַנְחֵהוּ וַאֲשַׁלֵּם
נִחֻמִים לוֹ וְלַאֲבֵלָיו: בּוֹרֵא נִיב
שְׂפָתָיִם[i] שָׁלוֹם שָׁלוֹם לָרָחוֹק
וְלַקָּרוֹב[ii] אָמַר יְיָ וּרְפָאתִיו: אָז
יִבָּקַע כַּשַּׁחַר אוֹרֶךָ וַאֲרֻכָתְךָ
מְהֵרָה תִצְמָח וְהָלַךְ לְפָנֶיךָ צִדְקֶךָ
כְּבוֹד יְיָ יַאַסְפֶךָ: לֹא יָבוֹא עוֹד
שִׁמְשֶׁךָ וִירֵחֲךָ לֹא יֵאָסֵף כִּי יְיָ
יִהְיֶה לְךָ לְאוֹר עוֹלָם וְשָׁלְמוּ
יְמֵי אֶבְלֶךָ:[iii] כִּי אַתָּה אָבִינוּ
כִּי אַבְרָהָם לֹא יְדָעָנוּ וְיִשְׂרָאֵל
לֹא יַכִּירֵנוּ אַתָּה יְיָ אָבִינוּ גֹּאֲלֵנוּ
מֵעוֹלָם שִׁמֶךָ: וְעַתָּה יְיָ אָבִינוּ אָתָּה
אֲנַחְנוּ חֹמֶר וְאַתָּה יֹצְרֵנוּ וּמַעֲשֵׂה
יָדְךָ כֻּלָּנוּ: יָדַעְתִּי יְיָ כִּי לֹא
לָאָדָם דַּרְכּוֹ לֹא לְאִישׁ הֹלֵךְ וְהָכִין
אֶת צַעֲדוֹ: מֵאֵין כָּמוֹךָ יְיָ גָּדוֹל
אַתָּה וְגָדוֹל שִׁמְךָ בִּגְבוּרָה:[iv]

him and restore comfort to him and to his mourners. Creating the fruit of the lips, "Peace, peace, to the far and to the near," says the LORD, "and I will heal him." Then your light shall break forth like the dawn,[1] and your healing shall spring up quickly; your righteousness shall go before you, and the glory of the LORD shall be your rear guard. Your sun shall no more go down, nor shall your moon withdraw itself; for the LORD will be your everlasting light, and your days of mourning shall be ended. For You are our Father, though Abraham does not know us and Israel does not recognize us. You, O LORD, are our Father; our Redeemer from everlasting is Your name. And now, O LORD, You are our Father; we are the clay, and You are our potter;[2] we are all the work of Your hand. I know, O LORD, that the way of man is not in himself; it is not in one who walks to direct his steps.[3] There is none like You, O LORD; You are great, and Your name is great in might.

1285R 1290R 1295R

(תהלים) אֶרֶץ נָתְנָה יְבוּלָהּ
יְבָרְכֵנוּ אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהֵינוּ: יְבָרְכֵנוּ

(Psalms) The earth has yielded its produce; may God, our God, bless us. May God bless us, and may

1300R

[1]This metaphor of light breaking forth connects to Ma'avar Yabok's central theme of spiritual illumination through proper practice, particularly at times of suffering and transition.
[2]This potter-clay metaphor acknowledges divine sovereignty over human life and death, supporting the book's emphasis on accepting divine judgment even at the moment of death.
[3]This acknowledgment of human limitation in controlling one's path reflects Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on spiritual surrender, particularly important in its deathbed rituals.

[i]The phrase "creating the fruit of the lips" is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as it suggests that divinely inspired speech (including prayers, confessions, and biblical recitations) has creative power that can facilitate healing.
[ii]"To the far and to the near" in rabbinic interpretation often refers to various categories of people: those distant from God who have repented and those who were always near, or alternatively, deceased souls (distant) and living people (near).
[iii]The promise that "your days of mourning shall be ended" has special resonance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of deathbed and mourning rituals, offering spiritual comfort by framing death as a transition to a state beyond grief.
[iv]Cf. Isaiah 57:18-19 — These verses from Isaiah express God's promise of healing and peace, which aligns with the book's themes of offering spiritual comfort during illness and death. The 'far and near' imagery establishes universal scope for divine healing. | Cf. Isaiah 58:8 — This verse connects righteous action with divine healing and protection, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation for death and illness as a means of accessing divine mercy. | Cf. Isaiah 60:20 — This promise of eternal divine light and the end of mourning resonates with the book's concept of death as transition to a higher spiritual state, offering comfort to the dying and their mourners. | Cf. Isaiah 63:16 — This affirms God's paternal relationship with Israel even when the patriarchs seem distant, providing a source of comfort for the dying who might feel abandoned by earthly connections. | Cf. Isaiah 64:8 — The potter-clay metaphor expresses divine sovereignty over human life, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's theme of acceptance of divine judgment at the time of death. | Cf. Jeremiah 10:23 — This acknowledges human limitation and dependence on divine guidance, supporting the book's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation and surrender at the time of death. | Cf. Jeremiah 10:6 — This verse exalts divine incomparability and might, establishing God's supreme authority as a source of both awe and comfort in the face of death.

אֱלֹהִים וְיִירְאוּ אֹתוֹ כָּל אַפְסֵי
אָרֶץ: בָּרוּךְ אֲדֹנָי יוֹם יוֹם יַעֲמָס
לָנוּ הָאֵל יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ סֶלָה: הָאֵל לָנוּ
אֵל לְמוֹשָׁעוֹת וְלַיהוִה אֲדֹנָי לַמָּוֶת
1170 תּוֹצָאוֹת: [i]הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי אֱלֹהִים כִּי
בָאוּ מַיִם עַד נָפֶשׁ: [ii]טָבַעְתִּי בִּיוֵן
מְצוּלָה וְאֵין מָעֳמָד בָּאתִי בְמַעֲמַקֵּי
מַיִם וְשִׁבֹּלֶת שְׁטָפָתְנִי: וַאֲנִי תְפִלָּתִי
לְךָ יְיָ עֵת רָצוֹן [iii]אֱלֹהִים בְּרָב
1175 חַסְדֶּךָ עֲנֵנִי בֶּאֱמֶת יִשְׁעֶךָ: הַצִּילֵנִי
מִטִּיט וְאַל אֶטְבָּעָה אִנָּצְלָה מִשֹּׂנְאַי
וּמִמַּעֲמַקֵּי מָיִם: עֲנֵנִי יְיָ כִּי טוֹב
חַסְדֶּךָ כְּרֹב רַחֲמֶיךָ פְּנֵה אֵלָי:
וְאַל תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מֵעַבְדֶּךָ כִּי צַר
1180 לִי מַהֵר עֲנֵנִי: וַאֲנִי עָנִי וְכוֹאֵב
יְשׁוּעָתְךָ אֱלֹהִים תְּשַׂגְּבֵנִי: אֱלֹהִים
לְהַצִּילֵנִי יְיָ לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה: יֵבֹשׁוּ
וְיַחְפְּרוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי נַפְשִׁי יִסֹּגוּ אָחוֹר
וְיִכָּלְמוּ חֲפֵצֵי רָעָתִי: וַאֲנִי עָנִי
1185 וְאֶבְיוֹן אֱלֹהִים חוּשָׁה לִי עֶזְרִי
וּמְפַלְטִי אַתָּה יְיָ אַל תְּאַחַר: בְּךָ
יְיָ חָסִיתִי אַל אֵבוֹשָׁה לְעוֹלָם:
בְּצִדְקָתְךָ תַּצִּילֵנִי וּתְפַלְּטֵנִי הַטֵּה
אֵלַי אָזְנְךָ וְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי: הֱיֵה לִי
1190 לְצוּר מָעוֹן לָבוֹא תָּמִיד צִוִּיתָ
לְהוֹשִׁיעֵנִי כִּי סַלְעִי וּמְצוּדָתִי
אָתָּה: אֱלֹהַי פַּלְּטֵנִי מִיַּד רָשָׁע מִכַּף

all the ends of the earth fear Him. Blessed is the Lord, day by day He bears our burden, God is our salvation, Selah. Our God is a God of salvation, and to the LORD God belong escapes from death.[A] Save 1305R
me, O God, for the waters have reached my soul. I have sunk in muddy depths with no foothold;[B] I have come into deep waters, and the current has swept me away.[C] But as for me, my prayer is to You, O LORD, at a favorable time; O God, in Your abundant kind- 1310R
ness, answer me with the truth of Your salvation. Rescue me from the mire and let me not sink; may I be saved from those who hate me and from the depths of the waters. Answer me, O LORD, for Your kindness is good; according to Your abundant 1315R
mercies, turn to me. Do not hide Your face from Your servant, for I am in distress; hasten to answer me. But I am poor and in pain; may Your salvation, O God, set me on high. O God, to deliver me; O LORD, to help me, hasten. May those who seek my 1320R
life be ashamed and disgraced; may those who desire my harm retreat backward and be humiliated. But I am poor and needy; O God, hasten to me. You are my help and my deliverer; O LORD, do not delay. In You, O LORD, I have taken refuge; let me never 1325R
be put to shame. In Your righteousness, rescue me and deliver me; incline Your ear to me and save me. Be to me a rock of habitation[1] to which I may con-

[A] Or: "and to the LORD God belong the pathways out of death" — This alternate translation more directly captures the sense of "totzaot" as "exits" or "pathways out," emphasizing God's control over death's boundaries. This interpretation particularly aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's focus on the soul's journey through death.

[B] Or: "I have sunk in miry depths with nothing to stand upon" — This alternate translation preserves the concrete physical image while emphasizing the complete absence of support or foundation, which may better convey the psychological and spiritual experience of severe illness or approaching death.

[C] Or: "and the flood current has overwhelmed me" — The Hebrew "shibbolet" specifically suggests a rushing flood or torrent rather than a regular current. This more dramatic translation better conveys the overwhelming nature of serious illness or approaching death.

[1] The Hebrew "tzur ma'on" combines two powerful metaphors: the rock (representing strength

[i] This phrase, literally "to the Lord God belong the issues of death," establishes a theological foundation particularly relevant to Ma'avar Yabok's purpose: death is under divine control, not random misfortune. This perspective provides comfort to the dying by placing their experience within a framework of divine sovereignty.

[ii] The image of waters reaching to the "nefesh" (soul/life-breath) is particularly significant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok. The Hebrew term "nefesh" refers to the vital soul connected to physical life, which in kabbalistic thought remains near the body after death. This verse poetically depicts the experience of approaching death as the vital forces being overwhelmed.

[iii] The concept of "et ratzon" (time of favor) is significant in Jewish mystical tradition, suggesting there are particularly auspicious moments when divine mercy is more accessible. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this phrase suggests that illness and approaching death may actually constitute such a time of divine receptivity to prayer.

מְעֻגָל וְחוֹמֵץ: כִּי אַתָּה תִקְוָתִי
אֲדֹנָי יְיָ מִבְטַחִי מִנְּעוּרָי: אַל
1195 תַּשְׁלִיכֵנִי לְעֵת זִקְנָה כִּכְלוֹת כֹּחִי
אַל תַּעַזְבֵנִי:[i] אֱלֹהִים אַל תִּרְחַק
מִמֶּנִּי אֱלֹהַי לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה: יֵבֹשׁוּ
יִכְלוּ שֹׂטְנֵי נַפְשִׁי יַעֲטוּ חֶרְפָּה
וּכְלִמָּה מְבַקְשֵׁי רָעָתִי: וַאֲנִי תָּמִיד
1200 אֲיַחֵל וְהוֹסַפְתִּי עַל כָּל תְּהִלָּתֶךָ:
תְּרַנֵּנָה שְׂפָתַי כִּי אֲזַמְּרָה לָּךְ
וְנַפְשִׁי אֲשֶׁר פָּדִיתָ:[ii] גַּם לְשׁוֹנִי
כָּל הַיּוֹם תֶּהְגֶּה צִדְקָתֶךָ כִּי בֹשׁוּ
כִי חָפְרוּ מְבַקְשֵׁי רָעָתִי: כִּי יַצִּיל
1205 אֶבְיוֹן מְשַׁוַּע וְעָנִי וְאֵין עֹזֵר לוֹ:
בָּרוּךְ יְיָ אֱלֹהִים אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
עֹשֵׂה נִפְלָאוֹת לְבַדּוֹ: וּבָרוּךְ שֵׁם
כְּבוֹדוֹ לְעוֹלָם וְיִמָּלֵא כְּבוֹדוֹ אֶת
כֹּל הָאָרֶץ אָמֵן וְאָמֵן: אַךְ טוֹב
1210 לְיִשְׂרָאֵל אֱלֹהִים לְבָרֵי לֵבָב: וַאֲנִי
אַל[iii]
תָּמִיד עִמָּךְ אָחַזְתָּ בְּיַד יְמִינִי:
תַּשְׁבִּחֵם קוֹל צוֹרְרֶיךָ שְׁאוֹן קָמֶיךָ
עֹלֶה תָּמִיד: שָׂמָה שִׁבַּר רִשְׁפֵי קָשֶׁת
מָגֵן וְחֶרֶב וּמִלְחָמָה סֶלָה: וְכָל
1215 קַרְנֵי רְשָׁעִים אֲגַדֵּעַ תְּרוֹמַמְנָה
קַרְנוֹת צַדִּיק:[iv]

tinually come; You have commanded to save me, for
You are my rock and my fortress. My God, deliver 1330R
me from the hand of the wicked, from the grasp of
the unjust and oppressor. For You are my hope, O
Lord GOD, my trust from my youth. Do not cast me
off in the time of old age; when my strength fails, do
not forsake me. O God, do not be far from me; my 1335R
God, hasten to my help. May the adversaries of my
soul[1] be ashamed and consumed; may those who seek
my harm be covered with reproach and humiliation.
But as for me, I will always hope, and I will add to all
Your praise. My lips will sing joyously when I sing 1340R
to You, and my soul, which You have redeemed. My
tongue also will speak of Your righteousness all day
long,[2] for those who seek my harm are ashamed, for
they are disgraced. For He will deliver the needy who
cry out, and the poor who have no helper. Blessed 1345R
is the LORD God, the God of Israel, who alone does
wonders. And blessed is His glorious name forever,
and may His glory fill the whole earth, Amen and
Amen. Surely God is good to Israel, to the pure of
heart. But as for me, I am continually with You; 1350R
You have grasped my right hand. Do not forget the
voice of Your adversaries, the tumult of those who

and stability) and habitation/dwelling (representing intimate presence and protection). This rich phrase suggests both God's immovable strength and accessible presence.

[1] The Hebrew "sotnei nafshi" (literally "adversaries of my soul") uses the term "satan" (adversary) which has particular resonance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok. In Jewish mystical tradition, the soul facing death encounters various spiritual accusers that this prayer seeks protection from.

[2] The commitment to constant verbal praise reflects the Jewish emphasis on speech as a powerful spiritual act. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this verse can be understood as expressing hope that even when physical speech fails, the soul will continue its spiritual articulation of divine praise.

[i] This verse from Psalm 71 was traditionally associated with prayers for the elderly and infirm, making it particularly appropriate in Ma'avar Yabok's context of ministering to the sick and dying. The fear of abandonment in old age or illness is directly addressed with a plea for continued divine presence.

[ii] The pairing of lips singing praise with the redeemed soul reflects the Jewish concept that bodily expressions of devotion should emerge from genuine spiritual transformation. This is particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context of preparing for death, suggesting that even when the body fails, the redeemed soul continues its praise.

[iii] The image of God grasping the right hand has particular resonance in Jewish mystical tradition. The right side is associated with mercy (chesed) while the left with judgment (din). This phrase thus suggests divine mercy actively supporting the worshipper even in times of judgment such as illness.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 67:6-8 — These verses open this prayer compilation with a theme of divine blessing and universal acknowledgment of God, establishing a foundation of trust in divine bounty. | Cf. Psalm 68:20 — The reference to God as one who has power over death adds a profound dimension to this prayer sequence, particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of providing comfort to the sick and dying. | Cf. Psalm 69:2-3, 14-18, 30-31 — The imagery of being overwhelmed by waters represents the experience of serious illness or approaching death. The psalmist's plea for rescue serves as a model prayer for those in distress. | Cf. Psalm 70 — The urgency of these verses reflects the pressing nature of prayer during critical illness, with enemies potentially representing

rise against You, which ascends continually. There He broke the fiery arrows of the bow, the shield, the sword, and the battle, Selah. I will cut off all the horns of the wicked,[1] but the horns of the righteous shall be exalted. 1355R

(כתובים) בְּשֵׁשׁ צָרוֹת יַצִּילֶךָּ
וּבְשֶׁבַע לֹא יִגַּע בְּךָ רָע:[i]
בָּרָעָב פָּדְךָ מִמָּוֶת וּבְמִלְחָמָה מִיַּד חָרֶב:
1220 בְּשׁוֹט לָשׁוֹן תֶּחְבָּא וְלֹא תִירָא
מְשֹׁד כִּי יָבוֹא: לְשֹׁד וְלָכָפָן תִּשְׂחָק
וּמֵחַיַּת הָאָרֶץ אַל תִּירָא: וְיָדַעְתָּ
כִּי שָׁלוֹם אָהֳלֶךָ וּפָקַדְתָּ נָוְךָ וְלֹא
תֶחֱטָא:[ii] וְיָדַעְתָּ כִּי רַב זַרְעֶךָ
1225 וְצֶאֱצָאֶיךָ כְּעֵשֶׂב הָאָרֶץ: תָּבוֹא
בְכֶלַח אֱלִי קָבֶר כַּעֲלוֹת גָּדִישׁ
בְּעִתּוֹ:[iii] מִי יִתֵּן תָּבוֹא שֵׁאֲלָתִי

(Writings) From six troubles He will deliver you, and in seven no evil shall touch you.[2] In famine He will redeem you from death, and in war from the power of the sword. From the scourge of the tongue you shall be hidden,[3] and you shall not fear destruction when it comes. At destruction and famine you shall laugh, and of the beasts of the earth you shall not be afraid. You shall know that your tent is at peace; when you inspect your dwelling, you will find nothing missing.[A] You shall know that your offspring are many, and your descendants like the grass of the 1360R 1365R

[A] Or: "when you attend to your abode, nothing will be amiss" — The Hebrew verb 'תֶּחֱטָא' has the root meaning of 'missing the mark' and in this context refers to finding one's dwelling in perfect order rather than the concept of sin. This alternate rendering emphasizes the sense of everything being in its proper place.

[1] The image of cutting off horns (symbols of power and pride) provides a fitting conclusion to this prayer compilation, suggesting that God will ultimately nullify all opposing forces—whether human enemies, illness, or death itself.

[2] This passage begins with verses from Job 5:19-26, which contain Eliphaz's speech to Job describing the protection God offers to those who accept divine correction. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses serve as reassurance that divine protection remains available even during illness.

[3] The 'scourge of the tongue' refers to slander or harmful speech. In the context of illness and approaching death, this may take on additional meaning—protection from harmful words that might disturb one's peace of mind during vulnerable moments.

both human adversaries and the spiritual forces of death and illness. | Cf. Psalm 71:1-8, 9, 12-24 — This psalm's inclusion is particularly apt for Ma'avar Yabok as it addresses the vulnerability of old age and illness while maintaining trust in divine deliverance—a model of faith in the face of mortality. | Cf. Psalm 72:18-19 — The inclusion of this doxology shows how the compiler of this prayer sequence maintains liturgical structures even while selecting verses for healing and comfort. | Cf. Psalm 73:1, 23 — These verses emphasize the intimate relationship between the worshipper and God even in times of trouble, reinforcing the theme of divine presence during illness and approaching death. | Cf. Psalm 74:23 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the enemies mentioned could be interpreted as both human adversaries and the spiritual forces of illness and death. | Cf. Psalm 76:4 — The image of God breaking weapons of war provides comfort that God has power over all destructive forces, including illness and death. | Cf. Psalm 75:11 — The final verse provides reassurance that God will ultimately judge the wicked and exalt the righteous, providing closure to the prayer sequence with a note of confidence in divine justice.

[i] This opening verse from Job 5:19 establishes a pattern of divine protection against increasing adversity, with the numbers six and seven symbolizing completeness and perfection in biblical numerology.

[ii] The Hebrew term 'תֶּחֱטָא' here is better understood as 'missing' or 'lacking' rather than 'sinning.' The verse promises that upon inspecting one's dwelling, nothing will be found missing or out of place.

[iii] This metaphor compares a person's life cycle to that of grain—both reach fullness in their appointed time before being gathered. 'בְּכֶלַח' (bekelach) refers to full maturity or ripeness.

וְתִקְוָתִי יִתֵּן אֱלוֹהַּ: מַה כֹּחִי כִי אֶיחָל וּמַה קִצִּי כִי אַאֲרִיךְ נַפְשִׁי: אַחַי בָּגְדוּ כְמוֹ נָחַל כַּאֲפִיק נְחָלִים יַעֲבֹרוּ:[i] וּמַלְטוּנִי מִיַּד צָר וּמִיַּד עָרִיצִים תִּפְדּוּנִי:[ii][iii]

earth. You shall come to the grave in full age,[A] like a sheaf of grain gathered in its season.[1] Oh, that my request might come, and that God would grant my hope! What strength do I have, that I should hope? And what is my end, that I should prolong my life? My brothers have dealt deceitfully like a wadi,[B] like the torrents of wadis that pass away. Deliver me from the hand of the adversary, and redeem me from the hand of the ruthless.[2]

רְפָא נָא אֵל מְשׁוּבָתִי[iv] וְהוֹאֵל. וְהָפֵק מִמְעוֹן קָדְשֶׁךָ[v] רְצוֹנִי:

Please heal my backsliding, O God,[C] and be willing[D] to fulfill my desire from Your holy

[A] Or: "You shall come to the tomb in ripe old age" — The term 'בְּכֶלַח' (bekelach) specifically refers to ripeness or full maturity, and this alternate translation better captures the agricultural metaphor that continues in the following phrase about the sheaf of grain.

[B] Or: "My brethren have betrayed me like a seasonal stream" — This alternate translation clarifies the nature of the betrayal by making explicit the seasonal, unreliable nature of the stream (nachal) being referenced, which would be immediately understood by the original audience but might be less clear to modern readers.

[C] Or: "Please heal my repentance, O God" — The word 'meshuvati' (מְשׁוּבָתִי) can refer to both 'backsliding/apostasy' and 'repentance/return.' While 'backsliding' fits the context of seeking healing from sin, the alternate translation emphasizes the positive aspect of the person's attempt to return to God, suggesting they're asking God to perfect their incomplete repentance.

[D] Or: "and consent" — The term 'וְהוֹאֵל' carries connotations of willing consent or agreement.

[1] This agricultural metaphor for a timely, natural death would be particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's framework of seeing death not as punishment but as a natural transition when properly prepared for. It suggests that a good death comes at the proper time, like harvesting ripe grain.

[2] The final verse appears to be compiled from elsewhere, creating a prayer that moves from promises of protection through honest lament to a direct petition for divine intervention. This structure mirrors the spiritual journey of the sick person from hope to despair to renewed faith.

[i] This is a significant shift in tone and speaker in the original text, moving from promises of protection to personal lament. The metaphor refers to seasonal streams in desert regions that appear full but quickly dry up, leaving travelers stranded.

[ii] The final verse seems to be a compilation from elsewhere in the Bible and shifts from the lament back to a prayer for deliverance, creating a circular structure that begins and ends with divine protection.

[iii] Cf. Book of Job — This passage consists primarily of verses from Job 5:19-26 and Job 6:11-15, which in their original context represent the theological dialogue between Job and his friend Eliphaz about suffering, divine protection, and human despair. Ma'avar Yabok incorporates these verses to acknowledge both the promise of divine protection and the reality of human despair during illness. | Cf. Psalm 91 — While not directly quoted, this passage echoes themes from Psalm 91, known as the 'Song of Protection,' which also promises divine deliverance from various dangers including 'the pestilence that walks in darkness' and 'the destruction that wastes at noonday.' Ma'avar Yabok frequently draws on Psalm 91 for its protective qualities during illness. | Cf. Biblical Wadis — The metaphor of deceptive brothers being like seasonal wadis (desert streams that dry up) would resonate deeply with readers familiar with Middle Eastern geography. Just as travelers rely on these streams for survival in the desert, the sick person relies on supporters who might prove unreliable, making divine assistance all the more necessary.

[iv] This phrase echoes God's promise in Hosea 14:5 to 'heal their backsliding' (אֶרְפָּא מְשׁוּבָתָם), turning God's third-person promise about Israel into a first-person plea. The term 'meshuvah' carries a dual meaning of both apostasy/backsliding and the act of returning/repentance.

[v] This phrase 'from Your holy dwelling' appears in biblical texts like Deuteronomy 26:15 and Jeremiah 25:30, referring to God's heavenly abode. It emphasizes the transcendent nature of God while acknowledging His ability to interact with the earthly realm.

1235 תִּרְצֵנִי לְמַעַנֶךָ וְלֹא לְמַעֲנִי.[i] וְנָא
אֱלֹהַי אַל תְּבִישֵׁנִי בְּדִינִי:[ii]

dwelling.[A] Accept me for Your sake, not for my own,[B] and please, my God, do not put me to shame in my judgment.[1] 1380R

מנחה ליום רביעי

Afternoon Prayer for Wednesday

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[iii] ואח״כ
יתחיל מזמור הושיעני אלהים
1240 וגו׳[iv] תהלים סי׳ ס״ט תמצא
לעיל[v] אח״כ יאמר זה

One should recite the verses beginning with "Please, O LORD"[2] and afterward begin Psalm 69, "Save me, O God,[3] etc." (which can be found above[4]), and then recite this. 1385R

(תורה) יְבָרֶכְךָ יְיָ וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ: יָאֵר
יְיָ פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ: יִשָּׂא יְיָ פָּנָיו
אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם:[vi] וְיִהִי

(Torah) May the LORD bless you and protect you. May the LORD cause His face to shine upon you and be gracious to you. May the LORD lift up His face to 1390R

While 'be willing' captures the essence, 'consent' might better convey the formal, almost contractual nature of the divine response being requested.

[A]Or: "grant from Your holy abode what I wish" — The verb 'תְּפַק' has connotations of producing, furnishing, or granting. This alternate translation emphasizes the action of granting coming from God's heavenly dwelling rather than focusing on the fulfillment aspect.

[B]Or: "Find favor in me for Your sake, not for my own" — The root of 'תִּרְצֵנִי' (r-tz-h) carries connotations of favor, acceptance, and goodwill. This alternate translation captures the nuance of divine favor rather than simple acceptance.

[1]This concluding petition acknowledges the reality of divine judgment while appealing to God's mercy. It reflects the tension in Jewish theology between divine justice and mercy, with the supplicant hoping that mercy will prevail in the final accounting.

[2]The Hebrew 'Ana Hashem' is a formulaic opening for prayers that appears at the beginning of each of the eight liturgical sequences in Ma'avar Yabok.

[3]Psalm 69 opens with an urgent plea for divine rescue from overwhelming circumstances, making it particularly appropriate in the context of serious illness or approaching death.

[4]The text assumes the reader has access to the complete prayer book or manuscript, where the full text of Psalm 69 would have appeared earlier.

[i]This reflects the theological concept that divine favor comes not through human merit but through God's own inherent mercy and for the sake of His name or glory—a theme prominent in biblical texts like Ezekiel 36:22.

[ii]Cf. Hosea 14:5 — The prayer directly echoes God's promise in Hosea to 'heal their backsliding,' transforming God's third-person promise about Israel into a first-person plea. This allusion frames the supplicant's request within God's established covenant promise of restoration upon repentance. | Cf. Psalm 38:1-2 — The final line 'do not put me to shame in my judgment' echoes the sentiment of Psalm 38, which begins with a plea to not be judged harshly. Both texts acknowledge divine judgment while appealing to God's mercy rather than strict justice. | Cf. Deuteronomy 26:15 — The phrase 'from Your holy dwelling' (מִמְּעוֹן קָדְשֶׁךָ) directly references the biblical language used in prayers requesting divine intervention from heaven. This connects the personal prayer to the traditional liturgical framework of addressing God in His transcendent abode.

[iii]These verses beginning with 'Ana Hashem' (Please, O LORD) serve as a standard opening formula for each of the eight prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok.

[iv]This refers to Psalm 69, which begins with 'Hoshieni Elohim' (Save me, O God). This psalm contains themes of distress, plea for divine intervention, and confidence in God's deliverance, making it particularly appropriate for prayers related to illness and suffering.

[v]The instruction indicates that the full text of Psalm 69 can be found earlier in the book, rather than being repeated here.

[vi]This is the Priestly Blessing (Birkat Kohanim) from Numbers 6:24-26, traditionally recited by the kohanim (priests) to bless the congregation. In Ma'avar Yabok, it serves as a powerful opening for healing prayers.

בִּנְסֹעַ הָאָרֹן וַיֹּאמֶר מֹשֶׁה קוּמָה
יְיָ וְיָפֻצוּ אֹיְבֶיךָ וְיָנֻסוּ מְשַׂנְאֶיךָ
מִפָּנֶיךָ:[i] בִּי אֲדֹנִי אַל נָא תָּשֵׁת
עָלֵינוּ חַטָּאת אֲשֶׁר נוֹאַלְנוּ וַאֲשֶׁר
חָטָאנוּ: אֵל נָא רְפָא נָא לָהּ:[ii] סֶלַח
נָא לַעֲוֹן הָעָם הַזֶּה כְּגֹדֶל חַסְדֶּךָ
וְכַאֲשֶׁר נָשָׂאתָה לָעָם הַזֶּה מִמִּצְרַיִם
וְעַד הֵנָּה:[iii] וַיֹּאמֶר יְיָ סָלַחְתִּי
כִּדְבָרֶךָ:[iv]

you and grant you peace.[1] And when the Ark would journey,[A] Moses would say, "Rise up, O LORD, and let Your enemies be scattered, and let those who hate You flee from before You."[2] Please, my Lord, do not hold against us the sin we have so foolishly committed.[B] Please God, heal her now.[3] Please forgive the iniquity of this people according to the greatness of Your loving-kindness, just as You have borne this people from Egypt until now. And the LORD said, "I have forgiven according to your word."[4] 1395R 1400R

(נביאים) יַסְּרַנִי יְיָ אַךְ בְּמִשְׁפָּט

(Prophets) Discipline me, O LORD, but with jus-

[A] Or: "And whenever the Ark set forth" — This alternative translation emphasizes the recurring nature of the action with 'whenever' rather than 'when' and uses 'set forth' which has a more formal, ceremonial connotation appropriate to the Ark's movement. This might better capture the ritual context of the original verse.

[B] Or: "I pray, my Lord, do not lay upon us the sin wherein we have acted foolishly and wherein we have sinned" — This more literal translation preserves the repetitive structure of 'wherein we have...' that appears in the Hebrew text, and more clearly shows that the speaker is taking responsibility for two separate actions: acting foolishly and sinning.

[1] The threefold structure of the Priestly Blessing corresponds in Kabbalah to the three primary divine attributes of Chesed (Loving-kindness), Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), and Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), creating a balanced flow of divine energy to the recipient.

[2] In the context of healing prayers, these 'enemies' are often interpreted as both physical illness and the negative spiritual forces (kelipot) that might be causing or exacerbating the condition.

[3] This five-word prayer in Hebrew (El na refa na lah) is considered one of the most concise and powerful healing formulas in Jewish tradition. Its brevity has been interpreted as demonstrating that effective prayer need not be lengthy but must be heartfelt.

[4] This divine response completes the sequence of prayers, offering reassurance that sincere prayer and confession can indeed bring divine forgiveness and healing. This creates a theological framework where physical healing is connected to spiritual forgiveness.

[i] This verse from Numbers 10:35 was traditionally recited when the Ark of the Covenant was transported in the wilderness. In kabbalistic tradition, it has protective power against harmful spiritual forces that might attack during illness.

[ii] This is Moses's brief but powerful prayer for his sister Miriam's healing from leprosy (Numbers 12:13). Its brevity and directness make it a paradigmatic healing prayer in Jewish tradition.

[iii] This prayer from Numbers 14:19 invokes God's past mercy as the basis for current forgiveness, a common pattern in Jewish prayers for healing and forgiveness.

[iv] Cf. Numbers 6:24-26 — The Priestly Blessing appears here as a protective prayer for the sick or dying person, invoking divine protection, grace, and peace. In Ma'avar Yabok, this blessing serves as a powerful opening for healing prayers, establishing divine protection over the ill person. | Cf. Numbers 10:35 — This verse invokes divine power against spiritual enemies, appropriate in the context of illness where negative forces might attack the vulnerable soul. In Ma'avar Yabok, this verse serves to disperse harmful spiritual entities that might gather around the sick. | Cf. Numbers 12:11 — This verse represents confession of sin as a prerequisite for healing, acknowledging that illness may result from spiritual failings. In Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, proper repentance and confession are essential components of healing. | Cf. Numbers 12:13 — This concise healing prayer serves as a model of effective intercession for the sick. Its brevity reflects Ma'avar Yabok's teaching that sometimes the simplest prayers, offered with proper intention, are most effective. | Cf. Numbers 14:19-20 — These verses emphasize divine forgiveness based on covenant faithfulness rather than human merit. In Ma'avar Yabok's approach to healing, this reflects the understanding that divine mercy, not human righteousness, is the foundation for recovery and spiritual restoration.

אַל בְּאַפְּךָ פֶּן תַּמְעִטֵנִי: וְאַתָּה יְיָ
יָדַעְתָּנִי תִּרְאֵנִי וּבְחַנְתָּ לִבִּי אִתָּךְ
הַתֵּקֶם כַּצֹּאן לְטִבְחָה וְתַקְדְּשֵׁם
לְיוֹם הֲרֵגָה: אִם עֲוֹנֵינוּ עֲנוּ בָנוּ יְיָ
עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ כִּי רַבּוּ מְשׁוּבֹתֵינוּ
לְךָ חָטָאנוּ: מִקְוֵה יִשְׂרָאֵל מוֹשִׁיעוֹ
בְּעֵת צָרָה לָמָּה תִהְיֶה כְּגֵר בָּאָרֶץ
וּכְאוֹרֵחַ נָטָה לָלוּן: לָמָּה תִהְיֶה
כְּאִישׁ נִדְהָם כְּגִבּוֹר לֹא יוּכַל
לְהוֹשִׁיעַ וְאַתָּה בְקִרְבֵּנוּ יְיָ וְשִׁמְךָ
עָלֵינוּ נִקְרָא אַל תַּנִּחֵנוּ: לָמָּה הָיָה
כְאֵבִי נֶצַח וּמַכָּתִי אֲנוּשָׁה מֵאֲנָה
הֵרָפֵא הָיוֹ תִהְיֶה לִי כְּמוֹ אַכְזָב
מַיִם לֹא נֶאֱמָנוּ: בָּרוּךְ הַגֶּבֶר אֲשֶׁר
יִבְטַח בַּיהוָה וְהָיָה יְיָ מִבְטַחוֹ:
וְהָיָה כְּעֵץ שָׁתוּל עַל מַיִם וְעַל
יוּבַל יְשַׁלַּח שָׁרָשָׁיו וְלֹא יִרְאֶה כִּי
יָבוֹא חֹם וְהָיָה עָלֵהוּ רַעֲנָן וּבְשְׁנַת
בַּצֹּרֶת לֹא יִדְאָג וְלֹא יָמִישׁ מֵעֲשׂוֹת
פֶּרִי: [i]

tice;[1] not in Your anger, lest You diminish me.[A] And
You, O LORD, have known me; You see me and
have tested my heart. Will You set them up like
sheep for slaughter and consecrate them for the day 1405R
of killing? If our iniquities testify against us, O
LORD, act for Your name's sake, for our rebellions
are many; against You we have sinned. O Hope of
Israel, its Savior in time of distress,[2] why are You like
a stranger in the land,[3] like a traveler who turns aside 1410R
to lodge for the night? Why are You like a confused
man,[B] like a warrior who cannot save? Yet You are
in our midst, O LORD, and Your name is called
upon us; do not forsake us. Why has my pain been
perpetual and my wound incurable,[4] refusing to be 1415R
healed?[C] Will You indeed be to me like a deceptive
stream,[D] like waters that cannot be trusted? Blessed
is the man who trusts in the LORD,[5] and whose trust
is the LORD. For he shall be like a tree planted
by waters, sending out its roots by a stream. It 1420R
does not fear when heat comes, and its leaves remain

[A] Or: "lest You reduce me to nothing" — This alternative better captures the fear of being utterly destroyed or annihilated by divine anger, rather than merely diminished. The Hebrew term can imply a severe reduction to insignificance.

[B] Or: "like a man astounded" — This alternative captures the sense of being stunned or astonished to the point of inaction, rather than merely confused. The image is of someone rendered momentarily incapable of action due to shock.

[C] Or: "resisting healing" — This alternative maintains the personification of the wound while slightly softening the sense of deliberate refusal, which might better reflect the experience of chronic illness that doesn't respond to treatment.

[D] Or: "like a disappointing spring" — This alternative captures the specific type of deception involved—not deliberate falsehood but the disappointment of a water source that appears promising but proves unreliable, particularly in the context of the extended water metaphor.

[1] This prayer compilation opens with verses from Jeremiah that perfectly capture the theological perspective of Ma'avar Yabok: illness is understood as divine discipline, but the sufferer may appropriately ask that this discipline be measured and just rather than overwhelming.

[2] The Hebrew מִקְוֵה (mikveh) means both "hope" and "gathering of waters" (as in ritual bath), creating a word play on the water imagery that appears throughout this prayer selection.

[3] These poignant questions express the spiritual alienation often felt during severe illness, when God seems distant or uninvolved. Ma'avar Yabok frequently acknowledges such feelings while still encouraging continued dialogue with the Divine.

[4] The Hebrew uses particularly strong terms: כְּאֵבִי נֶצַח ("my perpetual pain") and מַכָּתִי אֲנוּשָׁה ("my desperate/incurable wound"), expressing the physical and emotional reality of chronic suffering while maintaining the theological framework that God remains the ultimate healer.

[5] The prayer follows Ma'avar Yabok's typical pattern of moving from lament to affirmation. These concluding verses from Jeremiah 17 present trust in God as the solution to the spiritual crisis expressed in the earlier verses.

[i] Cf. Jeremiah 10:24 — This opening verse establishes the prayer's tone of accepting divine judgment while pleading for mercy. In Ma'avar Yabok, this reflects the attitude the sick person should adopt—acknowledging illness as divine correction while seeking compassionate healing. | Cf. Jeremiah 12:3 — This verse from Jeremiah's complaint against the wicked is transformed in this prayer context into a plea for the sick person not to be treated like those destined for destruction, emphasizing the distinction between corrective suffering and punitive judgment. | Cf. Jeremiah

green.[1] In the year of drought it does not worry, nor does it cease to yield fruit.

(תהלים) קוֹלִי אֶל אֱלֹהִים וְאֶצְעָקָה קוֹלִי אֶל אֱלֹהִים וְהַאֲזִין אֵלָי:[i] הַלְעוֹלָמִים יִזְנַח אֲדֹנָי וְלֹא יֹסִיף לִרְצוֹת עוֹד: וְהוּא רַחוּם יְכַפֵּר עָוֹן וְלֹא יַשְׁחִית וְהִרְבָּה לְהָשִׁיב אַפּוֹ וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ:[ii] וַיַּךְ צָרָיו אָחוֹר חֶרְפַּת עוֹלָם נָתַן לָמוֹ: עָזְרֵנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעֵנוּ עַל דְּבַר כְּבוֹד שְׁמֶךָ וְהַצִּילֵנוּ וְכַפֵּר עַל חַטֹּאתֵינוּ לְמַעַן שְׁמֶךָ: חָיִינוּ חֶרְפָּה לִשְׁכֵנֵינוּ לַעַג וָקֶלֶס לִסְבִיבוֹתֵינוּ: יְיָ אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת עַד מָתַי עָשַׁנְתָּ בִּתְפִלַּת עַמֶּךָ: יְיָ אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת הֲשִׁיבֵנוּ הָאֵר פָּנֶיךָ וְנִוָּשֵׁעָה: וַיַּאֲכִילֵהוּ מֵחֶלֶב חִטָּה וּמִצּוּר דְּבַשׁ אַשְׂבִּיעֶךָּ: פַּלְּטוּ דַל וְאֶבְיוֹן מִיַּד רְשָׁעִים הַצִּילוּ: אֱלֹהִים אַל דֳּמִי לָךְ אַל תֶּחֱרַשׁ וְאַל תִּשְׁקֹט אֵל: אֱלֹהַי שִׁיתֵמוֹ כַגַּלְגַּל כְּקַשׁ לִפְנֵי רוּחַ: כְּאֵשׁ תִּבְעַר יָעַר וּכְלֶהָבָה תְּלַהֵט הָרִים: כֵּן תִּרְדְּפֵם

(Psalms) My voice rises to God and I cry out; my voice rises to God, and He gives ear to me. Will the Lord reject forever and never again show favor?[A] But He is compassionate, forgives iniquity, and does not destroy; He frequently turns back His anger and does not arouse all His wrath.[2] He struck His adversaries backward, giving them everlasting disgrace. Help us, O God of our salvation, for the sake of Your name's glory; rescue us and atone for our sins for the sake of Your name. We have become a disgrace to our neighbors, a mockery and derision to those around us. O LORD God of Hosts, how long will You be angry with Your people's prayer? O LORD God of Hosts, restore us; make Your face shine upon us and we shall be saved. He fed him with the finest wheat, and with honey from the rock I would satisfy you. Deliver the poor and needy; rescue them from the hand of the wicked. O God, do not be silent; do not be quiet or still, O God. My God, make them like whirling dust, like chaff before the wind. As fire burns a forest, and as flame sets mountains ablaze, so pursue them with

[A] Or: "Will the Lord cast off forever and never again be favorable?" — This alternate rendering more directly translates the Hebrew verb יִזְנַח (yiznach) as "cast off" rather than "reject," and maintains the parallel structure of the original Hebrew.

[1] The image of the tree planted by water provides a powerful concluding visualization that the sick person can meditate upon. Even in the "heat" of affliction, one who remains connected to divine sources remains spiritually vital. This metaphor also recalls Psalm 1, creating an intertextual connection that enriches the prayer.

[2] The Hebrew construction וְלֹא יָעִיר כָּל חֲמָתוֹ literally means "and does not arouse all His wrath," emphasizing divine restraint rather than absence of judgment—an important theological nuance in the context of illness and suffering.

14:7-9 — These verses express the communal dimension of suffering, acknowledging that sins have collective consequences while appealing to God's reputation and covenant relationship. In Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that the sick person should recognize the spiritual roots of suffering while appealing to God's mercy. | Cf. Jeremiah 15:18 — This expresses the frustration of chronic illness and seemingly unanswered prayer, voicing the sick person's emotional distress while still remaining in dialogue with God. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:7-8 — The prayer concludes with hope, shifting from complaint to affirmation of the rewards of trusting God. This final section provides the sick person with a positive visualization of spiritual resilience despite physical circumstances, characteristic of Ma'avar Yabok's therapeutic approach of moving from distress to confidence.

[i] This opening from Psalm 77:2-3 establishes the prayer's dialogical nature—the human voice crying out and divine attention being given in response. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that properly directed prayer creates an actual channel between human and divine realms.

[ii] This verse from Psalm 78:38 is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's theology of illness as divine correction rather than punishment. It emphasizes God's restraint in judgment and establishes a theological framework of divine mercy that underpins the entire approach to death and suffering.

בְּסַעֲרֶךָ וּבְסוּפָתְךָ תְּבַהֲלֵם: מַלֵּא
פְנֵיהֶם קָלוֹן וְיְבַקְשׁוּ שִׁמְךָ יְיָ:
יֵבֹשׁוּ וְיִבָּהֲלוּ עֲדֵי עַד וְיַחְפְּרוּ
וְיֹאבֵדוּ: יְיָ אֱלֹהִים צְבָאוֹת שְׁמָעָה
תְפִלָּתִי הַאֲזִינָה אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה:
יְיָ צְבָאוֹת אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ:
הֹרֵאֵנוּ יְיָ חַסְדֶּךָ וְיֶשְׁעֲךָ תִּתֶּן
לָנוּ: גַּם יְיָ יִתֵּן הַטּוֹב וְאַרְצֵנוּ
תִּתֵּן יְבוּלָהּ: שַׂמַּח נֶפֶשׁ עַבְדֶּךָ כִּי
אֵלֶיךָ אֲדֹנָי נַפְשִׁי אֶשָּׂא: הַאֲזִינָה יְיָ
תְּפִלָּתִי וְהַקְשִׁיבָה בְּקוֹל תַּחֲנוּנוֹתָי:
בְּיוֹם צָרָתִי אֶקְרָאֶךָּ כִּי תַעֲנֵנִי:
אֲדֹנָי וְדִים קָמוּ עָלַי וַעֲדַת
עָרִיצִים בִּקְשׁוּ נַפְשִׁי וְלֹא שָׂמוּךָ
לְנֶגְדָּם: וְאַתָּה אֲדֹנָי אֵל רַחוּם
וְחַנּוּן אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב חֶסֶד וֶאֱמֶת:
פְּנֵה אֵלַי וְחָנֵּנִי תְּנָה עֻזְּךָ לְעַבְדֶּךָ
וְהוֹשִׁיעָה לְבֶן אֲמָתֶךָ: עֲשֵׂה עִמִּי
אוֹת לְטוֹבָה וְיִרְאוּ שֹׂנְאַי וְיֵבֹשׁוּ
כִּי אַתָּה יְיָ עֲזַרְתַּנִי וְנִחַמְתָּנִי:
תָּבוֹא לְפָנֶיךָ תְּפִלָּתִי הַטֵּה אָזְנְךָ
לְרִנָּתִי: כִּי שָׂבְעָה בְרָעוֹת נַפְשִׁי
וְחַיַּי לִשְׁאוֹל הִגִּיעוּ: נֶחְשַׁבְתִּי
עִם יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר הָיִיתִי כְּגֶבֶר אֵין
אֱיָל:[i] הָרַחֲקְתָּ מְיֻדָּעַי מִמֶּנִּי שַׂתַּנִי
תוֹעֵבוֹת לָמוֹ כָּלֹא וְלֹא אֵצֵא: עֵינִי
דָאֲבָה מִנִּי עֹנִי קְרָאתִיךָ יְיָ בְּכָל
יוֹם שִׁטַּחְתִּי אֵלֶיךָ כַּפָּי: וְשָׂרִים
בְּחֹלְלִים כָּל מַעְיָנַי בָּךְ:[iii ii]

Your tempest, and terrify them with Your storm. Fill their faces with shame, that they may seek Your name, O LORD. Let them be ashamed and dismayed forever; let them be humiliated and perish. O LORD God of Hosts, hear my prayer; listen, O God of Jacob, Selah. O LORD of Hosts, happy is the person who trusts in You. Show us Your kindness, O LORD, and grant us Your salvation. The LORD will also give what is good, and our land will yield its produce.[1] Gladden the soul of Your servant, for to You, O Lord, I lift up my soul. Give ear, O LORD, to my prayer, and attend to the voice of my supplications. In the day of my distress I call upon You, for You answer me. O God, arrogant men have risen against me, and a band of violent men seek my life, and they have not set You before them. But You, O Lord, are a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abundant in kindness and truth. Turn to me and be gracious to me; give Your strength to Your servant, and save the son of Your maidservant. Show me a sign for good, that my enemies may see and be ashamed, for You, O LORD, have helped me and comforted me. Let my prayer come before You; incline Your ear to my cry. For my soul is sated with troubles, and my life has reached the grave. I am counted among those who descend to the pit; I have become like a man without strength.[A] You have removed my acquaintances from me; You have made me an abomination to them; I am imprisoned and cannot

1450R 1455R 1460R 1465R 1470R 1475R

[A] Or: "I am reckoned among those descending to the grave; I have become like a warrior without might." — This alternate translation renders אֵין אֱיָל (ein eyal) as "without might" which more accurately captures the sense of lost power, and גֶּבֶר (gever) as "warrior" which better reflects its connotation of masculine strength in this context.

[1] This verse from Psalm 85:13 shifts from the previous themes of distress to express hope for divine blessing and restoration, reflecting the pattern throughout Ma'avar Yabok of moving from lamentation to confidence in divine response.

[i] This verse from Psalm 88:5-6 expresses the experience of approaching death through the metaphor of descending into "the pit" (בּוֹר), a common biblical euphemism for Sheol or the grave. The phrase "like a man without strength" (כְּגֶבֶר אֵין אֱיָל) has particular resonance in the context of terminal illness.

[ii] This final verse from Psalm 87:7 has particular mystical significance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok. The image of "wellsprings" (מַעְיָנַי) represents the soul's deepest spiritual sources flowing toward God, especially meaningful when recited by or for someone approaching death. In Kabbalistic thought, these wellsprings symbolize the channels connecting the human soul to divine realms.

[iii] Cf. Psalms — This passage is a compilation of verses from multiple psalms carefully selected to form a cohesive prayer for the sick or dying person. The selection follows a pattern seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok of creating therapeutic spiritual progressions from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation. | Cf. Zohar — Ma'avar Yabok draws heavily

go out. My eye wastes away because of affliction; I call to You, O LORD, every day; I spread out my hands to You. And singers as dancers declare: "All my wellsprings are in You.""[A]

(כתובים) גַּם אֲנִי לֹא אֶחְשָׂךְ פִּי
אֲדַבְּרָה בְּצַר רוּחִי אָשִׂיחָה בְּמַר
נַפְשִׁי: הֵן אֵל לֹא יִמְאַס תָּם וְלֹא
יַחֲזִיק בְּיַד מְרֵעִים: וְהָיָה רֵאשִׁיתְךָ
מִצְעָר וְאַחֲרִיתְךָ יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד: עַד
יְמַלֵּא שְׂחוֹק פִּיךָ וּשְׂפָתֶיךָ תְרוּעָה:
שֹׂנְאֶיךָ יִלְבְּשׁוּ בֹשֶׁת וְאֹהֶל רְשָׁעִים
אֵינֶנּוּ: גַּם הוּא לִי לִישׁוּעָה כִּי לֹא
לְפָנָיו חָנֵף יָבֹא: הֵן יִקְטְלֵנִי לוֹ
אֲיַחֵל אַךְ דְּרָכַי אֶל פָּנָיו אוֹכִיחַ:
בְּפִךָ מַעֲלַי הַרְחַק וְאִמָּתְךָ אַל
תְּבַעֲתַנִּי: כַּמָּה לִי עֲוֹנוֹת וְחַטָּאוֹת
פִּשְׁעִי וְחַטָּאתִי הוֹדִיעֵנִי: לָמָּה
פָנֶיךָ תַסְתִּיר וְתַחְשְׁבֵנִי לְאוֹיֵב לָךְ:
הֶעָלֶה נִדָּף תַּעֲרוֹץ וְאֶת קַשׁ יָבֵשׁ
תִּרְדֹּף:[i]

(Writings) I too will not restrain my mouth;[B] I will speak in the anguish of my spirit, I will complain in the bitterness of my soul. Behold, God does not reject the blameless, nor does He support evildoers. Though your beginning was small, your end will greatly increase. Until He fills your mouth with laughter[1] and your lips with shouts of joy. Your enemies will be clothed with shame, and the tent of the wicked will be no more. This too is my salvation, for no hypocrite shall come before Him. Even if He slays me, I will hope in Him;[C] yet I will argue my ways to His face. Remove Your hand from me, and let not Your terror frighten me. How many are my iniquities and sins? Make known to me my transgression and my sin. Why do You hide Your face and consider me Your enemy?[2] Will You frighten a driven leaf and

1480R 1485R 1490R 1495R

[A] Or: "And both singers and dancers proclaim: "All my sources are in You."" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the image of both singers and dancers participating in worship, and uses "sources" which might better convey the spiritual dependence implied by the Hebrew מַעְיָנַי (ma'yanai) in a modern context.

[B] Or: "I also will not hold back my speech" — This alternate translation emphasizes the act of speaking rather than the physical metaphor of the mouth, which might be more accessible to modern readers unfamiliar with biblical idioms.

[C] Or: "Behold, though He slay me, yet will I trust in Him" — This alternate translation follows the King James Version's rendering, which is more familiar to many English readers and has a poetic quality that captures the spiritual paradox expressed in this pivotal verse.

[1] The shift from first-person complaint to second-person promise of future joy creates a therapeutic progression within the prayer, moving from expressions of present suffering to anticipated relief. This pattern is characteristic of Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences.

[2] The feeling of divine abandonment or even hostility expressed here is a common spiritual experience during serious illness, and its inclusion in this prayer validates such feelings as legitimate expressions that can be brought before God.

on Zoharic concepts regarding prayer as a means of elevating the soul through cosmic realms. This compilation of verses is organized to guide the soul's ascent during illness or at the time of death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This compilation follows the pattern established elsewhere in Ma'avar Yabok, where biblical verses are arranged to create a therapeutic spiritual progression from expressions of distress to affirmations of divine salvation, helping the ill person or the dying to move through their spiritual journey.

[i] Cf. Book of Job — This passage is compiled from verses in the Book of Job, specifically from Job's responses to his suffering. These verses have been arranged to create a prayer expressing both deep distress and firm trust in divine justice. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses serve as part of a structured prayer sequence for the sick and dying, providing a biblically-based expression of spiritual struggle that validates the ill person's suffering while maintaining trust in God. | Cf. Psalm 57 — The phrase 'בְּצַר רוּחִי' (in the anguish of my spirit) echoes similar language in Psalm 57:2, creating a connection between Job's individual suffering and the psalmist's experience of distress and divine protection. This connection would suggest to the reader that just as the psalmist found refuge under God's wings during persecution, the sick person can find similar comfort.

pursue dry chaff?

דְּוֵה לֵבָב[i] אֲנִי נִצָּב וְנֶעֱצָב.[ii] וּמָה אֶעֱשֶׂה וְאָן אֶפְנֶה לְעֶזְרָה. לְךָ עֵינָי בְּתַחֲנוּנָי[iii] יְיָ בְּהַאֲנַחִי שִׂיחִי וְקוֹלִי:[iv]

With a sorrowful heart[1] I stand distressed.[2] What shall I do and where shall I turn for help? To You my eyes look in my supplications,[3] O LORD; when I sigh, heed my prayer and my voice.[4]

סדר יום חמישי

Order for Thursday

מתחיל פסוקי אנא ה׳ ואח״כ[v] יאמר מזמור בך ה׳ חסיתי[vi] וגו׳ סימן ע״א סדר ו׳[vii] ואח״כ יאמר זה:[viii]

Begin with the verses[5] “Ana Hashem” (Please, O LORD), and afterward recite Psalm 31 “In You, O LORD, I have taken refuge, etc.” as noted in section 71 of the sixth order,[A] and then say this:[6]

[A] Or: “marked as number 71 in the sixth sequence” — This alternate translation emphasizes the organizational system of Ma’avar Yabok more explicitly, making it clear that this refers to a numbering system within the text. Either translation effectively conveys the meaning.

[1] The Hebrew “deveh levav” literally means “faint-hearted” or “heart-sick,” conveying a state of profound emotional distress that affects one physically.

[2] I’ve attempted to preserve something of the wordplay in the Hebrew between “nitzav” (standing) and “ne’etzav” (distressed), though the full effect of the alliteration is lost in translation.

[3] This imagery of “lifting eyes” toward God is a common biblical prayer motif, appearing in Psalms 123:1-2, 141:8, and elsewhere, symbolizing hope and expectation directed toward heaven.

[4] The Hebrew “si’chi ve-koli” pairs two aspects of prayer: “siach” (meditation or prayer) and “kol” (voice), suggesting both the internal and external dimensions of the petitioner’s cry to God.

[5] This is a liturgical instruction found in Ma’avar Yabok directing the sick person or their attendant on the proper sequence of prayers to recite. It’s part of the book’s structured approach to providing spiritual comfort through organized prayer sequences.

[6] This instruction indicates that what follows (not shown in this excerpt) should be recited after the specified psalm. The book consistently provides detailed step-by-step instructions for prayer sequences.

[i] The phrase “deveh levav” (sorrowful heart) creates a powerful opening that establishes the emotional state of the petitioner. This kind of visceral, embodied description of distress is characteristic of Jewish prayer literature.

[ii] The Hebrew uses a play on words with the roots נצב (standing) and עצב (sorrow/distress), creating both alliteration and a connection between physical posture and emotional state.

[iii] This phrase echoes Psalm 141:8, “But my eyes are toward You, O GOD, my Lord,” emphasizing the directional focus of prayer as looking toward the divine.

[iv] This closing phrase draws on multiple psalm formulations, including elements from Psalms 5:2, 102:2, and others, using traditional language for divine attention to prayer.

[v] This refers to a standard opening formula that begins each of the eight prayer sequences in Ma’avar Yabok. Each sequence begins with verses starting with the words ‘Ana Hashem’ (Please, O LORD).

[vi] This is Psalm 31, which begins ‘In You, O LORD, I have taken refuge.’ This psalm is particularly appropriate for the sick and dying because it contains the verse ‘Into Your hand I commit my spirit’ (verse 6), which is recommended in Ma’avar Yabok for recitation at the moment of death.

[vii] This is a cross-reference to another section of Ma’avar Yabok, specifically section 71 in the sixth order of prayers (Seder Vav), where this psalm is also prescribed.

[viii] Cf. Section 71 of the Sixth Order (Seder Vav) — This cross-reference shows how Ma’avar Yabok creates a consistent system of prayer sequences while allowing for variations based on different days or conditions of the ill person. Psalm 31 appears in multiple prayer sequences due to its significance for the dying. | Cf. Psalm 31 — This psalm is particularly appropriate for the sick and dying because it contains the verse ‘Into Your hand I commit my spirit’ (verse 6), which tradition holds should be recited at the moment of death. Jesus reportedly quoted this verse on the cross, and it became a standard part of Jewish deathbed rituals.

(תורה) וְהִנֵּה פָּרַח מַטֵּה אַהֲרֹן
לְבֵית לֵוִי[i] וַיֹּצֵא פֶּרַח וַיָּצ֘ץ צִיץ
וַיִּגְמֹל שְׁקֵדִים: וַיֹּאמֶר יְיָ אֶל
אַהֲרֹן בְּאַרְצָם לֹא תִנְחָל וְחֵלֶק
1355 לֹא יִהְיֶה לְךָ בְּתוֹכָם אֲנִי חֶלְקְךָ
וְנַחֲלָתְךָ[ii] בְּתוֹךְ בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל: הִנֵּה
בֵרַךְ לָקַחְתִּי וּבֵרַךְ וְלֹא אֲשִׁיבֶנָּה:
חֵן עָם בְּלָעִיא יָקוּם וְכַאֲרִי יִתְנַשָּׂא
לֹא יִשְׁכַּב עַד יֹאכַל טֶרֶף וְדַם
1360 חֲלָלִים יִשְׁתֶּה:[iii] כָּרַע שָׁכַב כַּאֲרִי
וּכְלָבִיא מִי יְקִימֶנּוּ מְבָרֲכֶיךָ בָרוּךְ
וְאֹרְרֶיךָ אָרוּר: אֵיתָן מוֹשָׁבֶךָ וְשִׂים
בַּסֶּלַע קִנֶּךָ: לָכֵן אֱמֹר הִנְנִי נֹתֵן לוֹ
אֶת בְּרִיתִי שָׁלוֹם:[iv] וְאֹמַר אֲלֵכֶם
1365 [v] לֹא תַעֲרִצוּן וְלֹא תִירְאוּן מֵהֶם:

(Torah) And behold, Aaron's rod for the house of Levi had sprouted[1] and put forth buds, produced blossoms, and yielded almonds.[A] And the LORD said to Aaron, "In their land you shall have no inheritance, nor shall you have any portion among them; 1510R
I am your portion and your inheritance[2] among the children of Israel." Behold, I have received a command to bless, and He has blessed, and I cannot reverse it. Behold, a people rises like a lion, and
lifts itself up like a lion; it will not lie down until 1515R
it devours prey[3] and drinks the blood of the slain. He crouches, he lies down like a lion, and like a lion, who shall rouse him? Blessed are those who bless you, and cursed are those who curse you. Your
dwelling is enduring, and you set your nest in the 1520R

[A] Or: "and produced almonds" — This alternate translation maintains the same meaning but uses 'produced' which might be slightly more direct than 'yielded' in modern English.

[1] This miracle confirmed Aaron's divine appointment to the priesthood against challenges to his authority. In the liturgical context of Ma'avar Yabok, this image of miraculous blossoming would resonate as a symbol of spiritual legitimacy and divine favor.

[2] This powerful theological concept establishes a direct relationship between priests and God, suggesting that spiritual connection surpasses material possession. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this would remind readers that the soul's connection to God is the ultimate inheritance, more valuable than any worldly possession.

[3] The lion metaphors from Balaam's oracles were originally directed toward Israel as a nation, but in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they take on spiritual significance related to the soul's strength and divine protection during its journey.

[i] This section begins with a compilation of verses focused on priesthood and priestly blessing, starting with the confirmation of Aaron's divine selection through the miraculous blossoming of his rod.

[ii] This represents a fundamental principle of priesthood in Judaism: priests don't receive territorial inheritance but instead have a direct spiritual relationship with God who serves as their portion. This concept distinguishes them from other Israelites while also emphasizing their sacred status.

[iii] These verses from Balaam's oracles use powerful lion imagery to portray Israel's divinely-granted strength and inevitable victory. The vivid and even violent imagery (devouring prey, drinking blood) reflects ancient Near Eastern royal metaphors repurposed to describe spiritual power.

[iv] This reference to the 'covenant of peace' originally referred to God's promise to Phinehas (Aaron's grandson) after his zealous defense of Israelite religious purity. It became a significant concept in later Jewish mysticism representing harmony between divine and human realms.

[v] Cf. Numbers 17:23 — The flowering rod symbolizes the divine legitimacy of the priesthood, emphasizing Aaron's consecrated status and the spiritual authority of the priestly lineage. | Cf. Numbers 18:20 — This establishes the special relationship between God and the priests, who are separated from ordinary economic concerns to focus on spiritual service. | Cf. Numbers 23:20 — This verse emphasizes divine protection over Israel, showing that God's blessing cannot be undone even by those intending harm. | Cf. Numbers 23:24 — The lion imagery portrays Israel as divinely empowered and victorious, emphasizing their spiritual strength and eventual triumph over enemies. | Cf. Numbers 24:9 — This reinforces the divine protection over Israel and establishes the principle that one's treatment of Israel determines whether one receives blessing or curse. | Cf. Numbers 24:21 — This verse emphasizes security and permanence, suggesting divine protection for those who properly align themselves with sacred purposes. | Cf. Numbers 25:12 — The covenant of peace represents divine approval and special relationship with God, suggesting harmony between human and divine realms through proper religious observance. | Cf. Deuteronomy 1:29 — This verse offers spiritual reassurance against fear when facing challenges, suggesting that proper faith provides courage in difficult circumstances.

rock. Therefore say, "Behold, I give to him My covenant of peace."[1] And I said to you, "Do not be terrified, and do not be afraid of them.""[A]

(נביאים) רְפָאֵנִי יְיָ וְאֵרָפֵא[i] הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי וְאִוָּשֵׁעָה כִּי תְהִלָּתִי אָתָּה: יֵבֹשׁוּ רֹדְפַי וְאַל אֵבֹשָׁה אֲנִי יֵחַתּוּ הֵמָּה וְאַל אֵחַתָּה אֲנִי הָבִיא עֲלֵיהֶם יוֹם רָעָה וּמִשְׁנֶה שִׁבָּרוֹן שָׁבְרֵם: הַקְשִׁיבָה יְיָ אֵלַי וּשְׁמַע לְקוֹל יְרִיבָי: וַיהוָה אוֹתִי כְּגִבּוֹר עָרִיץ עַל כֵּן רֹדְפַי יִכָּשְׁלוּ וְלֹא יָכָלוּ[ii] בֹּשׁוּ מְאֹד כִּי לֹא הִשְׂכִּילוּ כְּלִמַּת עוֹלָם לֹא תִשָּׁכֵחַ: שִׁירוּ לַיְיָ הַלְלוּ אֶת יְיָ כִּי הִצִּיל אֶת נֶפֶשׁ אֶבְיוֹן מִיַּד מְרֵעִים: כִּי אָנֹכִי יָדַעְתִּי אֶת הַמַּחֲשָׁבֹת אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי חֹשֵׁב עֲלֵיכֶם נְאֻם יְיָ מַחְשְׁבוֹת שָׁלוֹם וְלֹא לְרָעָה[iii] לָתֵת לָכֶם אַחֲרִית וְתִקְוָה: הִנְנִי מַעֲלֶה לָהּ אָרְכָה וּמַרְפֵּא וּרְפָאתִים: עַל זֹאת הֵקִיצוֹתִי וָאֵרֶא וּשְׁנָתִי עָרְבָה לִי:[iv]

(Prophets) Heal me, O LORD, and I shall be healed;[2] save me, and I shall be saved, for You are my praise. Let my pursuers be put to shame, but let me not be put to shame; let them be dismayed, but let me not be dismayed. Bring upon them a day of evil and break them with double destruction. Listen to me, O LORD, and hear the voice of my adversaries. The LORD is with me like a mighty warrior;[3] therefore my pursuers will stumble and not prevail. They shall be greatly ashamed, for they have not acted wisely; their eternal disgrace will not be forgotten. Sing to the LORD! Praise the LORD! For He has delivered the soul of the needy from the hand of evildoers. For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil,[4] to give you a future and a hope. Behold, I will bring health and healing to it, and I will heal them. Upon this I awoke and looked around, and my sleep was sweet to me.[5]

[A] Or: "Do not dread them, and do not fear them" — This alternate captures the parallelism of the Hebrew with two different words for fear (dread and fear), though both translations effectively convey the meaning.

[1] The 'covenant of peace' (brit shalom) became an important mystical concept in Kabbalah, representing harmony between divine and human realms. In the context of death rituals, this would symbolize the soul's peaceful transition and divine protection during this passage.

[2] This prayer emphasizes complete dependence on divine healing rather than human intervention, reflecting the book's perspective that true healing addresses both physical and spiritual needs.

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'כְּגִבּוֹר עָרִיץ' (like a mighty warrior) portrays God as a powerful defender against both physical suffering and spiritual adversaries that might threaten the soul during illness or at death.

[4] This verse is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework, which consistently presents suffering as part of a benevolent divine plan rather than punishment, encouraging the sick to trust God's ultimate good intentions.

[5] The final image of sweet sleep provides a peaceful conclusion that, in the context of deathbed prayers, might be understood as a metaphor for the peaceful transition of death for the righteous.

[i] The Hebrew uses the Tetragrammaton (יְיָ) with a slightly unusual vocalization, as was common in prayer texts to avoid pronouncing the divine name.

[ii] The image of pursuers who stumble and fail has a spiritual dimension in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, potentially referring to the Angel of Death or harmful spiritual forces that threaten the dying person.

[iii] This powerful affirmation from Jeremiah 29:11 reframes suffering as part of a divine plan for ultimate good, aligning with Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theological approach to illness and death as spiritually purposeful rather than random misfortune.

[iv] Cf. Jeremiah 17:14 — This opening verse from Jeremiah's prayer for healing is particularly appropriate in the context of Ma'avar Yabok as it emphasizes complete dependence on divine healing rather than human means. The sick person acknowledges that true healing comes only from God. | Cf. Jeremiah 17:18 — This continues Jeremiah's prayer, moving from a request for personal healing to a plea for justice against his persecutors. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this could represent spiritual enemies or forces of illness. | Cf. Jeremiah 20:11-13 — These verses

(תהלים) וַאֲנִי אֵלֶיךָ יְיָ
שַׁוְּעָתִי[i] וּבַבֹּקֶר תְּפִלָּתִי תְקַדְּמֶךָּ:
לָמָה יְיָ תִּזְנַח נַפְשִׁי תַּסְתִּיר פָּנֶיךָ
מִמֶּנִּי: הֲרַחֲקְתָּ מִמֶּנִּי אֹהֵב וָרֵעַ
מְיֻדָּעַי מַחְשָׁךְ: כִּי לַיְיָ מָגִנֵּנוּ
וְלִקְדוֹשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל מַלְכֵּנוּ: בָּרוּךְ
יְיָ לְעוֹלָם אָמֵן וְאָמֵן: שַׂבְּעֵנוּ
בַבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ וּנְרַנְּנָה וְנִשְׂמְחָה
בְּכָל יָמֵינוּ: שַׂמְּחֵנוּ כִּימוֹת עִנִּיתָנוּ
שְׁנוֹת רָאִינוּ רָעָה: וְיִהִי נֹעַם
אֲדֹנָי אֱלֹהֵינוּ עָלֵינוּ וּמַעֲשֵׂה
יָדֵינוּ כּוֹנְנָה עָלֵינוּ וּמַעֲשֵׂה יָדֵינוּ
כּוֹנְנֵהוּ: יֹשֵׁב בְּסֵתֶר עֶלְיוֹן בְּצֵל
שַׁדַּי יִתְלוֹנָן:[ii] אֹמַר לַיְיָ מַחְסִי
וּמְצוּדָתִי אֱלֹהַי אֶבְטַח בּוֹ: לֹא
תְאֻנֶּה אֵלֶיךָ רָעָה וְנֶגַע לֹא יִקְרַב
בְּאָהֳלֶךָ: כִּי מַלְאָכָיו יְצַוֶּה לָךְ
לִשְׁמָרְךָ בְּכָל דְּרָכֶיךָ: עַל כַּפַּיִם
יִשָּׂאוּנְךָ פֶּן תִּגֹּף בָּאֶבֶן רַגְלֶךָ: עַל
שַׁחַל וָפֶתֶן תִּדְרֹךְ תִּרְמֹס כְּפִיר
וְתַנִּין: כִּי בִי חָשַׁק וַאֲפַלְּטֵהוּ
אֲשַׂגְּבֵהוּ כִּי יָדַע שְׁמִי: יִקְרָאֵנִי
וְאֶעֱנֵהוּ עִמּוֹ אָנֹכִי בְצָרָה אֲחַלְּצֵהוּ
וַאֲכַבְּדֵהוּ: אֹרֶךְ יָמִים אַשְׂבִּיעֵהוּ
וְאַרְאֵהוּ בִּישׁוּעָתִי: כִּי חָנַּה אֹיְבֶיךָ
יְיָ כִּי חָנַּה אֹיְבֶיךָ יֹאבֵדוּ יִתְפָּרְדוּ

(Psalms) But as for me, to You, O LORD, I cry out, and in the morning my prayer comes before You. Why, O LORD, do You reject my soul and 1545R
hide Your face from me?[1] You have distanced from me friend and companion; my acquaintances are in darkness. For our shield belongs to the LORD, and our king to the Holy One of Israel. Blessed is the LORD forever, Amen and Amen. Satisfy us in the 1550R
morning with Your lovingkindness,[A] that we may sing for joy and be glad all our days. Make us glad according to the days You have afflicted us, the years we have seen evil. May the pleasantness of the Lord our God be upon us, and establish the work of our 1555R
hands upon us; yes, establish the work of our hands. He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty.[2] I will say to the LORD, "My refuge and my fortress, my God, in whom I trust." No evil will befall you, nor will 1560R
any plague come near your tent. For He will command His angels concerning you, to guard you in all your ways. They will bear you up in their hands, lest you strike your foot against a stone.[3] You will tread upon the lion and cobra; you will trample the 1565R
young lion and serpent. "Because he loves Me, I will deliver him; I will set him securely on high, because he has known My name. He will call upon Me, and

[A] Or: "Fill us at daybreak with Your steadfast love" — This translation captures the sense of divine love as sustenance (like being filled with food) and emphasizes the motif of morning/daybreak as a time of renewal and hope, which is particularly relevant in prayers for healing.

[1] The Hebrew metaphor of God 'hiding His face' (הסתר פנים) is a key theological concept denoting divine withdrawal or apparent absence, particularly resonant during times of illness when one might feel abandoned by God.

[2] The imagery of divine shadow (צל) represents protective covering rather than darkness or obscurity. In a hot climate, shade provides life-saving refuge, making this an apt metaphor for divine protection during illness.

[3] This verse about angelic protection from even minor injuries (stubbing one's toe) emphasizes comprehensive divine care extending to the smallest details of the ill person's experience.

transition from distress to confidence in divine protection, showcasing the spiritual journey from affliction to trust that Ma'avar Yabok aims to facilitate for the sick or dying. | Cf. Jeremiah 29:11 — This well-known verse offers reassurance of God's benevolent plans. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would provide comfort that even suffering serves a divine purpose leading to hope. | Cf. Jeremiah 30:17 — This divine promise of healing would be particularly meaningful in Ma'avar Yabok's context, affirming God's commitment to restore health to the afflicted. | Cf. Jeremiah 31:26 — This concluding verse from Jeremiah describes awakening from a pleasant sleep, which in Ma'avar Yabok's context might symbolize the peaceful transition of death leading to spiritual awakening.

[i] This opening verse from Psalm 88:14 begins with a cry of distress, establishing the spiritual state of the ill person who feels abandoned yet still turns to God in prayer.

[ii] The transition to Psalm 91, which follows the opening laments, marks a shift from expressions of abandonment to declarations of divine protection. This psalm was traditionally recited for protection against harmful forces, both physical and spiritual.

כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן: צַדִּיק בַּתָּמֶר
יִפְרָח[i] כְּאֶרֶז בַּלְּבָנוֹן יִשְׂגֶּה: יְיָ
מָלָךְ גֵּאוּת לָבֵשׁ לָבֵשׁ יְיָ עֹז הִתְאַזָּר
אַף תִּכּוֹן תֵּבֵל בַּל תִּמּוֹט: אֵל
נְקָמוֹת יְיָ אֵל נְקָמוֹת הוֹפִיעַ:
אִם אָמַרְתִּי מָטָה רַגְלִי חַסְדְּךָ יְיָ
יִסְעָדֵנִי: בְּרֹב שַׂרְעַפַּי בְּקִרְבִּי
תַּנְחוּמֶיךָ יְשַׁעֲשְׁעוּ נַפְשִׁי:[ii] לְכוּ
נְרַנְּנָה לַיְיָ נָרִיעָה לְצוּר יִשְׁעֵנוּ:
כִּי טוֹב יְיָ לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ וְעַד דֹּר
וָדֹר אֱמוּנָתוֹ: שִׁירוּ לַיהוָה בָּרֲכוּ
שְׁמוֹ בַּשְּׂרוּ מִיּוֹם לְיוֹם יְשׁוּעָתוֹ:
שַׂמְּחוּ צַדִּיקִים בַּיהוָה וְהוֹדוּ
לְזֵכֶר קָדְשׁוֹ: זַמְּרוּ לַיְיָ בְּכִנּוֹר
בְּכִנּוֹר וְקוֹל זִמְרָה: רוֹמְמוּ יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְהִשְׁתַּחֲווּ לְהַר קָדְשׁוֹ כִּי
קָדוֹשׁ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ: לַבְּקָרִים אַצְמִית
כָּל רִשְׁעֵי אָרֶץ[iii] לְהַכְרִית מֵעִיר
יְיָ כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן: תְּפִלָּה לְעָנִי
כִּי יַעֲטֹף וְלִפְנֵי יְיָ יִשְׁפֹּךְ שִׂיחוֹ:
יְיָ שִׁמְעָה תְפִלָּתִי וְשַׁוְעָתִי אֵלֶיךָ
תָּבוֹא: אַל תַּסְתֵּר פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי בְּיוֹם
צַר לִי הַטֵּה אֵלַי אָזְנֶךָ בְּיוֹם אֶקְרָא
מַהֵר עֲנֵנִי:[iv]

I will answer him; I will be with him in trouble; I will rescue him and honor him. With long life I will satisfy him and show him My salvation." For behold, Your enemies, O LORD, for behold, Your enemies shall perish; all evildoers shall be scattered. The righteous will flourish like the palm tree; he will grow like a cedar in Lebanon. The LORD reigns, He is clothed with majesty; the LORD has clothed and girded Himself with strength; indeed, the world is firmly established, it will not be moved. The God of vengeance, O LORD, the God of vengeance, shine forth! When I said, "My foot is slipping," Your lovingkindness, O LORD, held me up.[A] When my anxious thoughts multiply within me,[1] Your consolations delight my soul. Come, let us sing joyfully to the LORD; let us shout to the rock of our salvation. For the LORD is good; His lovingkindness is everlasting, and His faithfulness to all generations. Sing to the LORD, bless His name; proclaim good tidings of His salvation from day to day.[B] Rejoice in the LORD, O righteous ones, and give thanks to His holy name. Sing praises to the LORD with the lyre, with the lyre and the sound of melody. Exalt the LORD our God and worship at His holy mountain,

[A] Or: "When I thought, "My foot is slipping," Your faithful love, O LORD, supported me" — This translation emphasizes the internal psychological state ('thought' rather than 'said') and uses 'supported' to maintain the physical metaphor of being upheld when one is about to fall—particularly apt for someone physically weakened by illness.

[B] Or: "Sing to the LORD, bless His name; announce His deliverance day after day" — The Hebrew 'בַּשְּׂרוּ' carries connotations of bringing good news or evangelizing. In the context of illness, 'deliverance' might better capture the sense of being rescued from affliction that would resonate with a sick person.

[1] The Hebrew term 'שַׂרְעַפַּי' refers specifically to divided or branching thoughts that multiply anxiety. This describes the psychological state of the ill person whose mind fills with worries and fears.

[i] This verse introduces the image of the righteous flourishing like a palm tree, which in Jewish tradition symbolizes resilience and fruitfulness even in harsh conditions—an apt metaphor for recovery from illness.

[ii] The Hebrew term 'יְשַׁעֲשְׁעוּ' (delight) has connotations of playthings or toys that bring comfort, suggesting divine consolations that soothe the troubled soul like a child's beloved toy.

[iii] In the context of prayers for the sick, this verse about destroying wickedness can be understood metaphorically as the elimination of illness and harmful spiritual forces that cause suffering.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 88:13-14 — These opening verses set the tone of spiritual distress and the sense of divine distance that the ill person is experiencing, making this an appropriate opening for prayer during suffering | Cf. Psalm 88:18 — The reference to being separated from loved ones would resonate particularly with someone who is ill or dying, as sickness often brings isolation | Cf. Psalm 89:18-19 — After the opening expressions of distress, the text shifts to affirmations of faith, establishing a theological foundation for the prayers that follow | Cf. Psalm 90:14-17 — These verses constitute a prayer for restoration and divine favor, appropriate for someone seeking healing and a return to normal life | Cf. Psalm 91:1-16 — Psalm 91 is central to Ma'avar Yabok's prayers for the sick and dying because of its traditional protective properties against spiritual and physical harm | Cf. Psalm 92:9-10 — This establishes a cosmic justice framework where those who harm the righteous

for holy is the LORD our God. Every morning I will destroy all the wicked of the land, to cut off from the city of the LORD all the evildoers. A prayer of 1595R
the afflicted when he is faint[1] and pours out his complaint before the LORD. O LORD, hear my prayer, and let my cry for help come to You. Do not hide Your face from me in the day of my distress; incline Your ear to me; in the day when I call, answer me 1600R
quickly.

(כתובים) מְלִיצַי רֵעָי אֶל אֱלוֹהַּ דָּלְפָה עֵינִי: [i] עַד אָנָה תּוֹגְיוּן נַפְשִׁי וּתְדַכְּאוּנַנִי בְמִלִּים: חָנֵּנִי חָנֵּנִי אַתֶּם רֵעָי כִּי יַד אֱלוֹהַּ נָגָעָה בִי: [ii] בַּמָּה נַר רְשָׁעִים יִדְעָךְ וְיָבֹא עֲלֵימוֹ אֵידָם חֶבָלִים יְחַלֵּק בְּאַפּוֹ: יִהְיוּ כְּתֶבֶן לִפְנֵי רוּחַ וּכְמֹץ גְּנָבַתּוּ סוּפָה: אֶרֶץ אַל תְּכַסִּי דָמִי וְאַל יְהִי מָקוֹם לְזַעֲקָתִי: גַּם עַתָּה הִנֵּה בַשָּׁמַיִם עֵדִי וְשָׁהֲדִי בַּמְּרוֹמִים: וְחָנֵּה שַׁדַּי בְּצָרֵיךְ וְכֶסֶף תּוֹעָפוֹת

(Writings) My intercessors, my friends,[A] to God my eye drops tears.[2] How long will you grieve my soul and crush me with words? Have pity on me, have pity on me, O my friends, for the hand of God has 1605R
touched me.[3] How often is the lamp of the wicked extinguished, and their calamity comes upon them! He distributes sorrows in His anger. They are like straw before the wind, and like chaff that the storm carries away. O earth, do not cover my blood, and let there 1610R
be no resting place for my cry! Even now, behold, my witness is in heaven, and my advocate is in the

[A] Or: "My advocates, my companions" — The term 'melitzai' has multiple connotations including advocate, interpreter, and mediator. In Job's context, he's referring to friends who should be advocating for him but are instead condemning him.

[1] The term 'יַעֲטֹף' (faint/overwhelmed) describes a state of being enveloped or wrapped in suffering, suggesting not just physical weakness but spiritual and emotional engulfment—a holistic description of serious illness.

[2] The Hebrew word 'melitzai' (מְלִיצַי) carries connotations of both 'intercessors' and 'interpreters'—those who speak on behalf of someone else. Job uses this term ironically, as his friends have failed to properly advocate for him before God.

[3] This powerful repetition of 'have pity' (חָנֵּנִי) reflects the intensity of the sufferer's plea. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse would be particularly resonant for the dying person seeking compassion from those attending them.

(metaphorically including illness and spiritual forces) will ultimately be defeated | Cf. Psalm 93:1 — Affirming God's kingship provides reassurance that even suffering occurs within a divinely governed cosmos | Cf. Psalm 94:1-2, 18-19 — These verses acknowledge both divine judgment and mercy, themes central to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of illness as potentially corrective but ultimately redemptive | Cf. Psalm 95:1 — The transition to expressions of praise models the movement from lament to hope that the sick person is encouraged to undergo | Cf. Psalm 96:2-3 — The emphasis on God's salvation reinforces hope for recovery or spiritual redemption | Cf. Psalm 97:12 — Continues the theme of moving from distress to joy through proper spiritual orientation | Cf. Psalm 98:5 — Music was considered healing in Jewish tradition, and this reference to instrumental worship suggests restoration of joy | Cf. Psalm 99:9 — References to divine holiness establish proper spiritual reverence in approaching God for healing | Cf. Psalm 101:8 — In the context of illness, this may be interpreted as eliminating spiritual forces causing suffering | Cf. Psalm 102:1-2 — The explicit identification of this as 'a prayer of the afflicted' makes it particularly appropriate for the sick

[i] This is a verbatim quote from Job 16:20-21, where Job is responding to his friends who have been offering unhelpful consolation during his suffering.

[ii] Direct quote from Job 19:21, a powerful plea for compassion that would resonate deeply with the sick or dying person and those attending them.

לָךְ׃[i] כִּי אָז עַל שַׁדַּי תִּתְעַנָּג וְתִשָּׂא
אֶל אֱלוֹהַּ פָּנֶיךָ׃ תַּעְתִּיר אֵלָיו
וְיִשְׁמָעֶךָּ וּנְדָרֶיךָ תְּשַׁלֵּם׃ וְתִגְזַר
אֹמֶר וְיָקָם לָךְ וְעַל דְּרָכֶיךָ נָגַהּ
1450 אוֹר׃[iii][ii]

heights.[1] The Almighty will be your defender,[A] and you will have silver in abundance.[B][2] For then you will delight yourself in the Almighty, and lift up your face to God. You will make supplication to Him, and He will hear you, and you will pay your vows. You will declare a matter, and it will be established for you; and light will shine on your ways. 1615R

נְחֵנִי נָא בְּאֹרַח הַנְכוֹנָה
לְפָנֶיךָ וְהָכֵן אֶת שְׁבִילִי׃ עֲנֵה
נַאֲקִי[iv] דְּלָתֶיךָ בְּדָפְקִי. רְאֵה
צוּרִי רְאֵה צִירִי[v] וְחֵילִי. פְּדֵנִי
1455 מֵעֲוֹנִי צוּר גְּאוֹנִי. אֱיָלוּתִי

Lead me, please, on the path that is right before You,[3] and prepare my way. Answer my groaning when I knock at Your doors.[4] See, my Rock, see my pain and my agony.[C] Redeem me from my iniquity,[5] Rock of my glory. My strength in my 1620R

[A] Or: "The Almighty will be against your adversaries" — The Hebrew 'b'tzarecha' can be interpreted as 'against your enemies' rather than 'your defender,' though both capture the protective aspect intended in this context.

[B] Or: "and precious silver shall be yours" — The term 'to'afot' has connotations of preciousness and height/exaltation rather than just abundance, potentially referring to spiritually refined or elevated silver rather than just quantity.

[C] Or: "my messenger and my strength" — The word 'צירי' could refer to physical pain/contractions, but it can also mean 'my messenger' or 'my emissary.' Similarly, 'חילי' can mean 'my agony' but more commonly means 'my strength/army.' This alternate translation reflects these other possible meanings, though the context suggests the pain/suffering interpretation is more likely.

[1] This expresses the paradoxical faith that even when suffering extreme divine judgment, God Himself will ultimately serve as advocate and witness for the sufferer—a central theological concept in Jewish approaches to suffering.

[2] While this appears to promise material prosperity in its original context, in Ma'avar Yabok it likely carries spiritual significance—the 'silver' representing spiritual merit and divine favor that accumulates through proper acceptance of suffering.

[3] This opening echoes traditional Jewish prayers for guidance, particularly relevant for someone facing illness or approaching death who seeks divine direction through their spiritual journey.

[4] The image of knocking at divine doors represents the urgent prayer of the sick or dying person, portrayed as directly petitioning at the gates of heaven for entry and mercy.

[5] This reflects Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theological framework that illness provides an opportunity for spiritual rectification and atonement for sin.

[i] From Job 22:25, part of Eliphaz's speech to Job, promising material prosperity if Job returns to God. In Ma'avar Yabok, this is repurposed as a promise of spiritual treasure for the suffering person.

[ii] From Job 22:28, also from Eliphaz's speech, promising that God will fulfill the requests of one who returns to Him. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this offers hope that prayers for healing or peaceful transition will be answered.

[iii] Cf. Book of Job — This passage is composed entirely of verses from the Book of Job, arranged to create a spiritual progression from despair to hope. By using Job's words, the author connects the experience of the sick or dying person with the biblical archetype of righteous suffering and faithful endurance. | Cf. Tziduk HaDin prayer — This compilation shares thematic similarities with the Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) prayer recited at funerals, which also acknowledges divine sovereignty even in suffering. Both texts move from acknowledging pain to affirming divine justice and ultimate hope. | Cf. Psalm 41 — The plea for compassion echoes Psalm 41, which focuses specifically on divine mercy during illness. Both texts emphasize how friends should respond to the suffering of the ill with compassion rather than judgment.

[iv] The term 'na'aki' (my groaning) conveys a deep visceral cry of distress, often used in biblical Hebrew to describe the anguished cries of the oppressed or suffering.

[v] There is wordplay between 'tzuri' (my Rock, referring to God) and 'tziri' (my pain), creating a poetic connection between the divine source of strength and the personal experience of suffering.

בְּגָלוּתִי[i] וֵאלֹי[ii]: — exile,[A] and my God. 1625R

מנחה ליום חמישי[iii] — Afternoon Prayer for Thursday

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[iv] ואחר כך יתחיל מזמור הודו לה וגו׳ תהלים ס מן קי״ח[v] סדר ח[vi] ואח״כ יאמר זה: — One should recite[1] the verses beginning with "Ana Hashem"[2] [Please, O LORD], and afterward begin Psalm 118 ("Hodu L'Hashem" [Give thanks to the LORD]), and then say this:[3] 1630R

(תורה) לַהֲדֹף אֶת כָּל אֹיְבֶיךָ מִפָּנֶיךָ כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר יְיָ: לֹא תִירָאוּם כִּי יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם הוּא הַנִּלְחָם לָכֶם:[vii] וְיָדַעְתָּ כִּי — (Torah) To thrust away all your enemies from before you, as the LORD has spoken: "Fear them not, for the LORD your God is the One who fights for you." And you shall know that the LORD your God, He is

[A] Or: "My help in my exile" — The term 'אילותי' is related to 'איל' (strength) but also has connotations of 'help' or 'assistance.' This alternative emphasizes the supportive aspect of God's presence during exile rather than just the strength aspect.

[1] The Hebrew uses the third-person formulation "יאמר" (he shall say), which is typical in liturgical instructions. I've translated it as "One should recite" to maintain the instructional tone while making it more inclusive in English.

[2] I've kept the Hebrew phrase "Ana Hashem" with a translation in brackets to preserve the specific prayer reference while making it accessible to English readers.

[3] This indicates that additional prayers would follow, which would have appeared in the next section of the text.

[i] The phrase combines 'my strength' with 'my exile,' reflecting the Kabbalistic understanding that even in states of spiritual or physical exile (including illness), divine strength remains accessible. The rhyming pattern (-uti) creates a poetic connection between God's sustaining power and the human experience of displacement.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 27:11 — The opening phrase "נְחֵנִי יְיָ בְּאֹרַח תַּנְכוֹנָה לְפָנֶיךָ" (Lead me, please, on the path that is right before You) directly echoes Psalm 27:11's plea for divine guidance on the proper path. This creates a connection between the sick/dying person's situation and David's plea for protection from enemies, suggesting that illness or approaching death is being metaphorically understood as an 'enemy' from which divine guidance provides protection. | Cf. Psalm 119:5 — The phrase "וְתָכֵן אֶת שְׁבִילִי" (and prepare my way) resonates with the psalmist's desire for his ways to be established in following divine law. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that the sick person desires divine assistance in establishing their spiritual path during their time of crisis, linking personal suffering to spiritual rectification. | Cf. Psalm 4:2 — The phrase "עֲנֵנִי בְּדָלְתֶיךָ דְּדָפְקִי" (Answer my groaning when I knock at Your doors) echoes the psalmist's call for divine response in Psalm 4:2. This creates a connection between the sick person's suffering and David's distress, positioning illness as a form of spiritual distress requiring divine attention and mercy. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — The phrase "פְּדֵנִי מֵעֲוֹנִי צוּר וְגוֹאֲלִי" (Redeem me from my iniquity, Rock of my glory) mirrors the imagery in Psalm 19:15 where God is addressed as "rock and redeemer." This creates a connection between the sick person's request for redemption from sin and David's prayer, establishing the theological framework where suffering provides an opportunity to address sin and seek divine redemption.

[iii] This is a header indicating the afternoon (Mincha) prayer service specifically for Thursday in the prayer sequence of Ma'avar Yabok.

[iv] These are standardized opening verses beginning with "Ana Hashem" (Please, O LORD) that appear at the beginning of each of Ma'avar Yabok's eight prayer sequences for the sick and dying.

[v] This refers to Psalm 118, which begins with "Hodu L'Hashem" (Give thanks to the LORD). The notation "תהלים ס מן קי״ח" appears to indicate "Psalm 118" with "ס" possibly being an abbreviation for "סימן" (mark/section).

[vi] This indicates that the text is part of the eighth liturgical order (Seder Het) in Ma'avar Yabok's system of structured prayer sequences for the sick and dying.

[vii] This phrase from Deuteronomy 3:22 contains divine reassurance that God will fight Israel's battles, which would be particularly comforting to the sick or dying person.

יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים הָאֵל
הַנֶּאֱמָן שֹׁמֵר הַבְּרִית וְהַחֶסֶד
לְאֹהֲבָיו וּלְשֹׁמְרֵי מִצְוֹתָיו לְאֶלֶף
דּוֹר: [i] וַאֲהֵבְךָ וּבֵרַכְךָ וְהִרְבֶּךָ
וּבֵרַךְ פְּרִי בִטְנְךָ וּפְרִי אַדְמָתֶךָ
דְּגָנְךָ וְתִירֹשְׁךָ וְיִצְהָרֶךָ שְׁגַר
אֲלָפֶיךָ [ii] וְעַשְׁתְּרֹת צֹאנֶךָ עַל
הָאֲדָמָה אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּע לַאֲבֹתֶיךָ לָתֵת
לָךְ: בָּרוּךְ תִּהְיֶה מִכָּל הָעַמִּים לֹא
יִהְיֶה בְךָ עָקָר וַעֲקָרָה וּבִבְהֶמְתֶּךָ:
וְנָתַתִּי עֵשֶׂב בְּשָׂדְךָ לִבְהֶמְתֶּךָ
וְאָכַלְתָּ וְשָׂבָעְתָּ: לֹא יִתְיַצֵּב אִישׁ
בְּפָנֶיכֶם פַּחְדְּכֶם וּמוֹרַאֲכֶם יִתֵּן יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵיכֶם עַל פְּנֵי כָל הָאָרֶץ אֲשֶׁר
תִּדְרְכוּ בָהּ כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר לָכֶם: וְלֹא
אָבָה יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ לִשְׁמֹעַ אֶל בִּלְעָם
וַיַּהֲפֹךְ יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ לְךָ אֶת הַקְּלָלָה
לִבְרָכָה [iii] כִּי אֲהֵבְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ: [iv]

God, the faithful God, who keeps the covenant and the loving-kindness for those who love Him and keep His commandments, to a thousand generations. And He will love you and bless you and multiply you; He will bless the fruit of your womb and the fruit of your land, your grain, your wine, and your oil, the increase of your cattle and the young of your flock,[A] on the land which He swore to your fathers to give you. You shall be blessed above all peoples; there shall be no barren male or female among you or among your livestock. And I will give grass in your fields for your livestock, and you shall eat and be satisfied. No man shall stand before you; the LORD your God will put the dread and fear of you upon all the land on which you tread, as He has spoken to you. And the LORD your God was not willing to listen to Balaam,[B] and the LORD your God turned the curse into a blessing for you, because the LORD your God loves you.[1]

1635R 1640R 1645R 1650R

(נביאים) בַּיָּמִים הָהֵם וּבָעֵת
הַהִיא נְאֻם יְיָ [v] יְבֻקַּשׁ אֶת עֲוֹן
יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאֵינֶנּוּ [vi] וְאֶת חַטֹּאת
יְהוּדָה וְלֹא תִמָּצֶאינָה כִּי אֶסְלַח

(Prophets) "In those days and at that time," declares the LORD, "the iniquity of Israel will be sought, but there will be none, and the sins of Judah, but they will not be found, for I will forgive those whom I

1655R

[A] Or: "the offspring of your cattle and the newborns of your flocks" — This alternative more directly captures the reproductive aspect of these Hebrew terms, which specifically refer to newborn livestock. The reproductive imagery may be significant in the context of prayers for healing and continuation of life.

[B] Or: "And the LORD your God refused to heed Balaam" — This alternative emphasizes God's active rejection of Balaam's attempts to curse Israel, rather than merely being 'unwilling' to listen, strengthening the image of divine protection.

[1] The passage concludes by grounding all the promises and protections in divine love, establishing love as the foundation of God's relationship with Israel. This personal expression of divine love would be particularly comforting to someone facing illness or death.

[i] From Deuteronomy 7:9, this emphasizes God's faithfulness to His covenant promises across generations, providing assurance of divine constancy in times of personal distress.

[ii] These terms refer specifically to the offspring of cattle and sheep, representing prosperity through abundant livestock reproduction. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these fertility blessings would resonate symbolically with continuation of life despite facing death.

[iii] This reference to God transforming Balaam's intended curse into a blessing (Deuteronomy 23:6) serves as a powerful metaphor for divine transformation of negative circumstances, especially relevant to illness which might be viewed as a 'curse' that can be transformed through divine love.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse Four — This passage exemplifies how Ma'avar Yabok structures healing prayers to follow a spiritual journey from distress through divine protection to ultimate redemption, with verses selected specifically to comfort the sick or dying person. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Memory Note #431 — The compiler of Ma'avar Yabok arranged biblical verses in a consistent pattern designed to lead the sick or dying person through a psychological and spiritual journey from fear to faith, with this passage exemplifying that approach.

[v] These opening words echo prophetic formulas that appear in Jeremiah and other prophetic books, introducing divine declarations about future redemption.

[vi] This passage is from Jeremiah 50:20, part of a prophecy about the restoration of Israel and the fall of Babylon.

לַאֲשֶׁר אֹשֵׁאיר: בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא
אַצְמִיחַ קֶרֶן לְבֵית יִשְׂרָאֵל[i] וּלְךָ
1490 אֶתֵּן פִּתְחוֹן פֶּה בְּתוֹכָם וְיָדְעוּ
כִּי אֲנִי יְיָ: אֲנִי אֶרְעֶה צֹאנִי וַאֲנִי
אַרְבִּיצֵם נְאֻם אֲדֹנָי יְיָ:[ii] וְגִלִּיתִי
לָהֶם עֲתֶרֶת שָׁלוֹם וֶאֱמֶת:[iii] וְנָתַן
עֵץ הַשָּׂדֶה אֶת פִּרְיוֹ[iv] וְהָאָרֶץ תִּתֵּן
1495 יְבוּלָהּ וְהָיוּ עַל אַדְמָתָם לָבֶטַח
וְיָדְעוּ כִּי אֲנִי יְיָ בְּשָׁבְרִי אֶת מֹטוֹת
עֻלָּם[v] וְהַצַּלְתִּים מִיַּד הָעֹבְדִים
בָּהֶם: וְהַצַּלְתִּיךְ בַּיּוֹם הַהוּא
נְאֻם יְיָ[vi] וְלֹא תִנָּתֵן בְּיַד הָאֲנָשִׁים
1500 אֲשֶׁר אַתָּה גָּוֹר מִפְּנֵיהֶם: וְזָרַקְתִּי
עֲלֵיכֶם מַיִם טְהוֹרִים[vii] וּטְהַרְתֶּם
מִכֹּל טֻמְאוֹתֵיכֶם וּמִכָּל גִּלּוּלֵיכֶם
אֲטַהֵר אֶתְכֶם: וְהוֹשַׁעְתִּי אֶתְכֶם
מִכֹּל טֻמְאוֹתֵיכֶם[viii] וְקָרָאתִי אֶל

leave as a remnant.[1] On that day I will cause a horn to sprout for the house of Israel,[2] and I will give you an opening of the mouth among them,[3] and they will know that I am the LORD. I Myself will shepherd 1660R
My flock,[4] and I Myself will make them lie down," declares the Lord GOD. "And I will reveal to them an abundance of peace and truth.[A] The tree of the field will yield its fruit, and the earth will give its produce, and they will dwell securely on their land. 1665R
Then they will know that I am the LORD, when I break the bars of their yoke[B] and deliver them from the hand of those who enslaved them. I will deliver you on that day," declares the LORD, "and you will not be given into the hand of the men whom you 1670R
fear.[C] I will sprinkle clean water upon you,[5] and you will be cleansed; from all your impurities and from all your idols I will purify you. I will save you

[A] Or: "And I will uncover for them a wealth of peace and truth" — The verb 'גִּלִּיתִי' has connotations of uncovering or revealing something that was previously hidden, which adds nuance to this promise of divine blessing.

[B] Or: "when I shatter the wooden crosspieces of their yoke" — This more specific translation emphasizes the physical components of the yoke being broken, highlighting the completeness of the liberation being promised.

[C] Or: "and you will not be handed over to the men before whom you tremble" — The verb 'גָּוֹר' suggests intense fear or dread rather than mere concern, conveying the emotional impact of facing powerful enemies.

[1] The concept of a 'remnant' (שארית/שאר) is significant in prophetic literature, referring to the survivors of catastrophe who will form the nucleus of a restored people.

[2] The Hebrew 'קֶרֶן' (horn) is a symbol of strength and power in biblical imagery. This prophecy suggests divine restoration of Israel's strength and dignity after a period of weakness.

[3] The phrase 'פִּתְחוֹן פֶּה' (opening of the mouth) refers to the ability to speak freely, especially in vindication after having been silenced or disbelieved.

[4] This divine shepherd imagery contrasts with the failed human leadership described earlier in Ezekiel 34, emphasizing God's direct intervention when human leaders fail.

[5] This imagery evokes ritual purification practices in ancient Israel, particularly the sprinkling of water mixed with ashes of the red heifer for purification from contact with the dead (Numbers 19).

[i] This phrase is from Ezekiel 29:21, where the 'horn' (קֶרֶן) symbolizes power, strength, and leadership—often interpreted as referring to a messianic figure or national restoration.

[ii] This verse comes from Ezekiel 34:15, part of an extended metaphor where God promises to be the shepherd of Israel after condemning the nation's negligent human leaders.

[iii] This appears to be an adaptation of a biblical phrase, with 'עֲתֶרֶת' (abundance/wealth) being a less common term in biblical Hebrew but appearing in rabbinic literature.

[iv] This passage draws from Ezekiel 34:27, describing the agricultural abundance that will accompany divine restoration.

[v] This phrase from Ezekiel 34:27 uses the metaphor of breaking the bars of a yoke, representing liberation from oppression or slavery.

[vi] This phrase comes from Jeremiah 39:17, originally addressed to Ebed-Melech the Ethiopian who had rescued Jeremiah from the cistern.

[vii] This verse from Ezekiel 36:25 uses the metaphor of ritual purification to describe spiritual cleansing and moral renewal.

[viii] This appears to be an adaptation of Ezekiel 36:29, which begins with a similar phrase but continues differently in the biblical text.

1505 הַדָּגָן וְהִרְבֵּיתִי אֹתוֹ וְלֹא אֶתֵּן
עֲלֵיכֶם רָעָב: [i]

from all your impurities, and I will call to the grain and make it abundant,[1] and I will not bring famine upon you." 1675R

(תהלים) כִּי אֵפֶר כַּלֶּחֶם אָכָלְתִּי
וְשִׁקָּוַי בִּבְכִי מָסָכְתִּי: מִקּוֹל אַנְחָתִי
דָּבְקָה עַצְמִי לִבְשָׂרִי: אֹמַר אֵלִי
1510 אַל תַּעֲלֵנִי בַּחֲצִי יָמָי בְּדוֹר דּוֹרִים
שְׁנוֹתֶיךָ: רַחוּם וְחַנּוּן יְהוָה אֶרֶךְ
אַפַּיִם וְרַב חָסֶד: לֹא לָנֶצַח יָרִיב
וְלֹא לְעוֹלָם יִטּוֹר: לֹא כַחֲטָאֵינוּ
עָשָׂה לָנוּ וְלֹא כַעֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ גָּמַל
1515 עָלֵינוּ: כִּי כִגְבֹהַּ שָׁמַיִם עַל הָאָרֶץ
גָּבַר חַסְדּוֹ עַל יְרֵאָיו: כְּרַחֵם אָב
עַל בָּנִים רִחַם יְיָ עַל יְרֵאָיו: בָּרְכוּ
יְיָ מַלְאָכָיו גִּבֹּרֵי כֹחַ עֹשֵׂי דְבָרוֹ
לִשְׁמֹעַ בְּקוֹל דְּבָרוֹ: בָּרְכוּ יְיָ כָּל
1520 צְבָאָיו מְשָׁרְתָיו עֹשֵׂי רְצוֹנוֹ: בָּרְכוּ
יְהוָה כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו בְּכָל מְקוֹמוֹת
מֶמְשַׁלְתּוֹ בָּרְכִי נַפְשִׁי אֶת יְהוָה:
יְהִי כְבוֹד יְיָ לְעוֹלָם יִשְׂמַח יְיָ
בְּמַעֲשָׂיו: הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה קִרְאוּ
1525 בִשְׁמוֹ הוֹדִיעוּ בָעַמִּים עֲלִילוֹתָיו:
יֵעָרֵב עָלָיו שִׂיחִי אָנֹכִי אֶשְׂמַח
בַּיהוָה: זָכְרֵנִי יְהוָה בִּרְצוֹן עַמֶּךָ
פָּקְדֵנִי בִישׁוּעָתֶךָ: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי
יִשְׂרָאֵל מִן הָעוֹלָם וְעַד הָעוֹלָם
1530 וְאָמַר כָּל הָעָם אָמֵן הַלְלוּיָהּ:

(Psalms) For I have eaten ashes like bread, and mingled my drink with weeping.[2] Because of my groaning my bones cleave to my flesh. I say, "My God, do not take me away in the midst of my days; Your years are throughout all generations." The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love. He will not always strive,[3] nor will He keep His anger forever. He has not dealt with us according to our sins, nor repaid us according to our iniquities. For as the heavens are high above the earth, so great is His steadfast love toward those who fear Him. As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. Bless the LORD, you His angels, mighty in strength, who perform His word,[4] hearkening to the voice of His word. Bless the LORD, all His hosts, His ministers who do His will. Bless the LORD, all His works, in all places of His dominion. Bless the LORD, O my soul. May the glory of the LORD endure forever; may the LORD rejoice in His works. Give thanks to the LORD, call upon His name; make known His deeds among the peoples. May my meditation be pleasing to Him; I will rejoice in the LORD. Remember me, O LORD, with the favor You show to 1680R 1685R 1690R 1695R 1700R

[1] This personification of grain responding to divine command highlights God's sovereignty over nature and ability to provide abundance, a key theme in restoration prophecies.

[2] This powerful image of tears mixing with drink conveys overwhelming grief where sorrow infiltrates even basic sustenance. The Hebrew phrase suggests that tears have become a constant accompaniment to life's necessities.

[3] The Hebrew verb יָרִיב (yariv) implies legal contention or dispute, suggesting that God does not perpetually maintain a state of judgment against humans, but rather limits the duration of divine rebuke.

[4] The description of angels emphasizes their role as agents of divine will rather than independent powers, contrasting with non-Jewish conceptions of angels that were prevalent in the ancient Near East.

[i] Cf. Ezekiel 34 — This passage draws heavily from Ezekiel's shepherd metaphor to communicate God's direct care for His people after human leadership has failed. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses would reassure the sick or dying person that God's care extends beyond earthly helpers. | Cf. Ezekiel 36:25-29 — The purification imagery would be particularly meaningful in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where spiritual cleansing before death is a central concern. The sprinkling of water symbolizes divine grace that purifies beyond what human efforts can accomplish. | Cf. Jeremiah 50:20 — This reference to complete forgiveness ('iniquity will be sought but there will be none') offers profound comfort to those approaching death, suggesting that divine mercy can completely erase sin, leaving no trace for accusation. | Cf. Jeremiah 39:17-18 — The original context of this verse shows God's protection extending even to non-Israelites who act righteously. In Ma'avar Yabok, this would suggest that divine deliverance is available to all who trust in God, regardless of status or background.

יֹאמְרוּ נְאוּלֵי יְיָ אֲשֶׁר גְּאָלָם מִיַּד
צָר: יוֹדוּ לַיְיָ חַסְדּוֹ וְנִפְלְאוֹתָיו
לִבְנֵי אָדָם: כִּי הִשְׂבִּיעַ נֶפֶשׁ שֹׁקֵקָה
וְנֶפֶשׁ רְעֵבָה מִלֵּא טוֹב: כִּי שִׁבַּר
1535 דַּלְתוֹת נְחֹשֶׁת וּבְרִיחֵי בַרְזֶל
גִּדַּע: יִשְׁלַח דְּבָרוֹ וְיִרְפָּאֵם וימלט
מִשְּׁחִיתוֹתָם: יוֹדוּ לַיְיָ חַסְדּוֹ וְנִפְלְאוֹתָיו
וַיָּשֶׂם כַּצֹּאן מִשְׁפָּחוֹת: בֵּאלֹהִים
נַעֲשֶׂה חָיִל וְהוּא יָבוּס צָרֵינוּ:
1540 עָזְרֵנִי יְהוָה אֱלָהָי הוֹשִׁיעֵנִי
כְּחַסְדֶּךָ: יְקַלְלוּ הֵמָּה וְאַתָּה
תְּבָרֵךְ קָמוּ וַיֵּבֹשׁוּ וְעַבְדְּךָ יִשְׂמָח:
נִשְׁבַּע יְהוָה וְלֹא יִנָּחֵם אַתָּה כֹהֵן
לְעוֹלָם עַל דִּבְרָתִי מַלְכִּי צֶדֶק:
1545 כִּי יַעֲמֹד לִימִין אֶבְיוֹן לְהוֹשִׁיעַ
מִשְׁפְּטֵי נַפְשׁוֹ: פְּדוּת שָׁלַח לְעַמּוֹ
צִוָּה לְעוֹלָם בְּרִיתוֹ קָדוֹשׁ וְנוֹרָא
שְׁמוֹ: זָרַח בַּחֹשֶׁךְ אוֹר לַיְשָׁרִים
חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם וְצַדִּיק: מְקִימִי מֵעָפָר
1550 דָּל מֵאַשְׁפֹּת יָרִים אֶבְיוֹן: הַהֹפְכִי
הַצּוּר אֲגַם מָיִם חַלָּמִישׁ לְמַעְיְנוֹ
מָיִם: בֵּית אַהֲרֹן בִּטְחוּ בַיהוָה
עֶזְרָם וּמָגִנָּם הוּא: יְיָ זְכָרָנוּ יְבָרֵךְ
יְבָרֵךְ אֶת בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל יְבָרֵךְ אֶת
1555 [i] בֵּית אַהֲרֹן:

Your people; visit me with Your salvation. Blessed be the LORD, God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting, and let all the people say, "Amen. Hallelujah." Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, whom He has redeemed from the hand of the adversary. 1705R
Let them give thanks to the LORD for His steadfast love, and for His wonderful works to the children of men. For He satisfies the longing soul,[1] and fills the hungry soul with goodness. For He has broken the gates of bronze, and cut the bars of iron in two. He 1710R
sends forth His word and heals them, and delivers them from their destructions.[A] He sets the needy securely on high, away from affliction, and makes their families like a flock. Through God we shall do valiantly,[B] and it is He who will tread down our 1715R
adversaries. Help me, O LORD my God; save me according to Your steadfast love. Let them curse, but You bless;[C] when they arise, they will be put to shame, but Your servant will rejoice. The LORD has sworn and will not change His mind, "You are a 1720R
priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek." For He stands at the right hand of the needy, to save him from those who condemn his soul.[2] He has sent redemption to His people; He has commanded His covenant forever; holy and awesome is His name. 1725R
Light dawns in the darkness for the upright; He is

[A] Or: "and rescues them from their deadly traps" — The Hebrew term מִשְּׁחִיתוֹתָם (shechitotam) has connotations of pits or traps set for destruction, not just abstract destruction. This alternate captures the sense of active deadly peril from which God rescues the sufferer.

[B] Or: "Through God we shall gain strength" — The Hebrew חַיִל (chayil) can mean 'strength' or 'army' as well as 'valor.' In the context of illness, 'gaining strength' might be more immediately relevant than military valor, though both capture aspects of the original meaning.

[C] Or: "They may curse, but You will bless" — The Hebrew could be rendered as a contrast between human action and divine response rather than as an imperative. This alternative better expresses confidence in God's blessing despite human negativity.

[1] The Hebrew נֶפֶשׁ שֹׁקֵקָה (nefesh shokeikah) depicts a soul in a state of intense yearning or thirst, suggesting spiritual as well as physical hunger that only divine satisfaction can quench.

[2] The phrase מִשְׁפְּטֵי נַפְשׁוֹ (mishoftei nafsho) can refer both to human judges who condemn unjustly and to spiritual accusers who bring charges against the soul in the divine court, a concept developed extensively in later Jewish mysticism.

[i] Cf. Psalm 102 — These verses from Psalm 102 express deep physical and emotional suffering, with the psalmist describing consuming ashes like bread and mixing tears with drink, suggesting extreme distress. This prayer would provide comfort to the sick by showing that even the biblical psalmist experienced profound suffering while maintaining faith. | Cf. Psalm 103 — These verses emphasize divine compassion and forgiveness, serving as a counterbalance to the suffering expressed in the opening verses. They would comfort the sick by affirming God's merciful nature and boundless love, suggesting that current afflictions are not punishments proportional to sins. | Cf. Psalm 104 — This verse shifts from personal distress to divine praise, helping the ill person transcend their immediate suffering by contemplating God's eternal glory. | Cf. Psalm 105 — This verse encourages the sick person to maintain gratitude even in suffering, suggesting that divine deliverance should be proclaimed to others. | Cf. Psalm 106 — These verses express

gracious, merciful, and righteous. He raises the poor from the dust, and lifts the needy from the ash heap. He turns the rock into a pool of water, the flint into a fountain of waters. O house of Aaron, trust in the 1730R
LORD; He is their help and their shield. The LORD has been mindful of us; He will bless us; He will bless the house of Israel; He will bless the house of Aaron.

(בתובים) וְתִגְזַר אֹומֶר וְיָקָם לָךְ[i] וְעַל דְּרָכֶיךָ נָגַהּ אוֹר: יְהִי כְרָשָׁע אֹיְבִי וּמִתְקוֹמְמַי כְּעַוָּל:[ii] וַיְהִי לְאֵבֶל כִּנֹּרִי וְעֻגָבִי
1560 לְקוֹל בֹּכִים:[iii] וַיְחָנֵּנוּ וַיֹּאמֶר פְּדָעֵהוּ מֵרֶדֶת שָׁחַת מָצָאתִי כֹפֶר:[iv] אִם עַל שַׁדַּי יִתְעַנָּג יִקְרָא אֱלוֹהַּ בְּכָל עֵת: פָּדָה

(Writings) You will decree a matter, and it will be established for you;[1] and light will shine upon your 1735R
ways. May my enemy be as the wicked, and my adversary as the unrighteous. My harp has turned to mourning, and my flute to the voice of those who weep. But He is gracious to him and says, "Deliver him from going down to the pit;[A] I have found a 1740R
ransom."[B] If he takes delight in the Almighty, he

[A] Or: "Redeem him from descending to the grave" — The term 'שָׁחַת' can refer to both a pit (physical) and corruption/destruction (spiritual). This alternate emphasizes the concrete image of the grave, which might be more immediately relevant in a deathbed context.

[B] Or: "I have found atonement" — The Hebrew 'כֹּפֶר' can mean both ransom (payment) and atonement (spiritual reconciliation). In Ma'avar Yabok's theological context, the spiritual dimension of atonement may be more appropriate.

[1] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse takes on special significance as it suggests the power of righteous speech to create spiritual realities, particularly important at the deathbed where proper words are believed to facilitate the soul's journey.

longing for God's favorable attention and salvation, appropriate for someone facing illness who seeks divine intervention. | Cf. Psalm 107 — These verses emphasize God's power to redeem, heal, and deliver, providing hope to the ill person that God can heal both physical and spiritual afflictions. | Cf. Psalm 108 — This verse portrays illness metaphorically as an enemy that God will help overcome, offering encouragement to the sick. | Cf. Psalm 109 — These verses would comfort the sick by suggesting that while others might abandon or even blame them for their illness, God's blessing supersedes human judgment. | Cf. Psalm 110 — The reference to Melchizedek introduces the concept of eternal priesthood, suggesting divine intercession on behalf of the suffering individual. | Cf. Psalm 111 — This verse reminds the ill person that God's covenant commitment remains valid even during suffering, offering security in divine faithfulness. | Cf. Psalm 112 — This verse offers hope that even in the darkness of illness, divine light and grace remain accessible to the righteous. | Cf. Psalm 113 — These verses metaphorically represent illness as a state of being cast down, with the promise that God can elevate even those in the most degraded conditions. | Cf. Psalm 114 — This verse uses the metaphor of God transforming rock into water to suggest that God can similarly transform illness into health and suffering into relief. | Cf. Psalm 115 — These concluding verses encourage the ill person to maintain trust in God as helper and protector, with assurance that divine blessing extends to all Israel, including the priestly house of Aaron.

[i] This verse from Job 22:28 is often used in Jewish tradition to emphasize the power of human decree when aligned with divine will. In the context of prayers for the sick or dying, it suggests that righteous speech has creative power.

[ii] From Job 27:7, this verse represents not a vindictive wish but a declaration that one's personal enemies should be judged according to universal standards of justice—those who act wickedly should be recognized as such.

[iii] From Job 30:31, this poignant verse expresses the transformation of instruments of joy into expressions of mourning, reflecting the emotional journey of illness or approaching death.

[iv] This verse from Job 33:24 introduces a powerful shift in the passage—from expressions of suffering to divine intervention and salvation. The term 'כֹּפֶר' (ransom/atonement) has deep theological significance in the context of death and redemption.

נַפְשׁוֹ מֵעֲבֹר בַּשָּׁחַת וְחַיָּתוֹ בָּאוֹר
תִּרְאֶה: [i] לְהָשִׁיב נַפְשׁוֹ מִנִּי שָׁחַת
לֵאוֹר בְּאוֹר הַחַיִּים: [ii] בְּצִדְקָתִי
הֶחֱזַקְתִּי וְלֹא אַרְפֶּהָ לֹא יֶחֱרַף
לִבָּבִי מִיָּמָי: [iii] אַף אָמָנָם אֵל לֹא
יַרְשִׁיעַ וְשַׁדַּי לֹא יַעֲוֹת מִשְׁפָּט: הֵן
אֵל בַּבִּיר וְלֹא יִמְאָס בַּבִּיר כֹּחַ
לֵב: לֹא יְחַיֶּה רָשָׁע וּמִשְׁפַּט עֲנִיִּים
יִתֵּן: [iv] [v]

will call upon God at all times. He has redeemed his soul from going into the pit, and his life shall see the light. To restore his soul from the pit, to be enlightened with the light of the living.[1] I hold fast to my righteousness and will not let it go; my heart shall not reproach me as long as I live.[2] Surely God will not act wickedly, and the Almighty will not pervert justice. Behold, God is mighty but does not despise; He is mighty in strength of understanding.[3] He does not preserve the life of the wicked, but gives justice to the afflicted. 1745R 1750R

שְׁעֵנִי נָא רְצֵנִי אֵל אֱמוּנָה. [vi] וְתִיטַב
לָךְ תְּשׁוּרַת מַהֲלָלַי תְּנַהֲלֵנִי בְּעוֹד
מְדַת צְבָאַי. [vii] וְתִרְעֵנִי יְמֵי חֶלְדִּי

Please support me and accept me, God of faithfulness.[A] May my offering of praise be pleasing to You.[B] Guide me throughout the measure of my 1755R

[A] Or: "Support me now, find favor in me, God of faithfulness" — This alternate translation preserves the pleading nature of 'נָא' (now/please) more explicitly and renders 'רְצֵנִי' with the idiom 'find favor' which might better capture the sense of divine acceptance.

[B] Or: "May the gift of my praise be good in Your sight" — This alternative more literally translates 'תְּשׁוּרַת' as 'gift' rather than 'offering' and preserves the Hebrew idiom of something being 'good in one's eyes/sight'.

[1] The 'light of the living' (אוֹר הַחַיִּים) carries dual meaning in Jewish mystical thought—referring both to restoration of physical life and to the spiritual illumination experienced by the soul in the afterlife.

[2] This declaration of moral integrity connects to Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation for death, including confession (vidui) to ensure the heart is free from reproach.

[3] The phrase 'כַּבִּיר כֹּחַ לֵב' literally 'mighty in strength of heart/mind' emphasizes that divine power includes perfect discernment and judgment, not merely physical strength.

[i] This verse from Job 33:28 uses the metaphor of redemption from 'the pit' (שחת), which can refer to both physical death and spiritual destruction. The contrast between the pit and light represents the transition from death to life.

[ii] From Job 33:30, this verse develops the light metaphor further with the powerful phrase 'אוֹר הַחַיִּים' (light of the living), suggesting both physical recovery and spiritual illumination.

[iii] Job 27:6 expresses steadfast moral integrity even in the face of suffering, a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok which emphasizes the spiritual importance of maintaining righteousness while confronting mortality.

[iv] This concluding verse from Job 36:6 affirms divine justice, providing comfort that ultimately God's judgment prevails—a key theological foundation for those facing death or grieving.

[v] Cf. Psalms 30 — Both texts establish a pattern of movement from descent to ascent, from darkness to light, which is central to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of illness and death as spiritual transitions rather than mere endings. | Cf. Zohar — The inclusion of Job 22:28 ('You will decree a matter...') in this prayer sequence reflects the kabbalistic belief that proper speech at the moment of death has creative power in determining the soul's journey. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This passage exemplifies the therapeutic structure seen throughout Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences: acknowledgment of distress, articulation of divine response, and affirmation of ultimate justice and redemption.

[vi] The phrase 'God of faithfulness' (אֵל אֱמוּנָה) appears in Deuteronomy 32:4, where God is described as 'the Rock, his work is perfect, for all his ways are justice; a God of faithfulness and without iniquity, just and upright is he.' This biblical allusion reinforces the supplicant's trust in God's reliability even in the face of mortality.

[vii] The term 'צְבָאַי' derives from a root meaning 'army' or 'host' and can refer to one's appointed service or time on earth. Job 7:1 uses the related term 'צָבָא' to describe life as a period of hard service. This military metaphor suggests the supplicant views life as a period of appointed duty with a finite duration.

וְחֶדְלִי:[ii i] time,[A] and shepherd me through the days of my existence and my passing.[B]

סדר יום ששי[iii] Order of Friday

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[iv] ואח״כ יתחיל מזמור שיר למעלות אשא עיני אל ההרים וגו׳ תהלים סי׳ קכ״א[v] סדר י׳[vi] אח״כ יאמר זה:[vii] One should recite the verses beginning with "Ana Hashem"[1] (Please, O LORD), and afterward begin the psalm "A Song of Ascents: I will lift up my eyes to the mountains, etc." (Psalm 121). [Follow] the tenth order,[2] after which one should say this:[3] 1760R

[A] Or: "Lead me throughout the span of my service" — The term 'צְבָאִי' comes from a root related to 'army' or 'service' and can be understood as one's appointed service or time on earth. This alternate captures that nuance more explicitly.

[B] Or: "and tend to me through the days of my fleeting life and my cessation" — This translation emphasizes the transitory nature implied in 'חֶלְדִּי' (from a root suggesting temporariness) and renders 'חֶדְלִי' more directly as 'cessation' rather than the euphemistic 'passing'.

[1] This is a standard liturgical instruction that appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok, indicating that the prayer sequence should begin with verses that start with "Please, O LORD" (אנא ה׳).

[2] While most of Ma'avar Yabok contains eight prayer sequences (sedarim), this reference to a "tenth order" (סדר י׳) suggests either an additional sequence not explicitly outlined elsewhere, or possibly refers to the tenth component within a particular sequence.

[3] This indicates that the text that would follow (not included in this segment) contains additional prayers or verses to be recited after Psalm 121.

[i] The pairing of 'חֶלְדִּי' (my lifetime/existence) with 'חֶדְלִי' (my cessation/death) creates a poetic expression encompassing the entirety of human experience from life to death. The root of 'חֶלֶד' suggests transience or fleeting existence, while 'חֶדֶל' implies cessation or coming to an end. Together they form a merism (a figure of speech using contrasting parts to refer to a whole) representing the complete human journey.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 23 — The prayer uses the same pastoral metaphor of God as shepherd ('תְּרָעֵנִי'—'shepherd me') found in Psalm 23. This creates a direct connection to the biblical psalm of comfort and divine protection, suggesting the supplicant sees themselves in need of the same divine guidance and care that David described. | Cf. Psalm 31:15 — The phrase 'בְּעוֹד מַדַּת צְבָאִי' (throughout the measure of my time) echoes the sentiment in Psalm 31:15 where the psalmist acknowledges that his times/destiny are in God's control. Both texts express surrender to divine guidance through the full course of one's life. | Cf. Job 7:1 — The term 'צְבָא' (my service/time) alludes to Job's description of life as 'צָבָא' (hard service/warfare), suggesting the prayer's author views life as a period of appointed service with struggles that require divine guidance.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This heading marks the beginning of the Friday prayer sequence in the structured liturgical system organized by days of the week. Each day has specific prayers, psalms, and biblical verses recommended for the sick and dying, with special spiritual intentions (kavanot) corresponding to that day's unique energies.

[iv] "Ana Hashem" (Please, O LORD) verses serve as a standard opening for each of the eight prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, establishing a consistent ritual framework.

[v] Psalm 121, "I lift up my eyes to the mountains," was considered especially appropriate for the sick and dying due to its themes of divine protection. In Ma'avar Yabok, it appears in several prayer sequences and was specifically recommended to be recited three times as a protective measure.

[vi] This refers to the tenth liturgical sequence (Seder Yod) in Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer system for the sick and dying.

[vii] Cf. Psalm 121 — This psalm was considered particularly appropriate for the sick and dying because of its themes of divine protection. Its declaration that 'the LORD is your keeper' and 'the LORD will keep you from all evil' would have been especially comforting to someone facing illness or death. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok prayer sequences — This passage follows the established pattern of Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences, showing how the author created a systematic framework for prayers for the sick and dying that was consistent across different days of the week.

(תורה) וַנִּצְעַק אֶל יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי
אֲבֹתֵינוּ[i] וַיִּשְׁמַע יְיָ אֶת קֹלֵנוּ
וַיַּרְא אֶת עָנְיֵנוּ וְאֶת עֲמָלֵנוּ וְאֶת
לַחֲצֵנוּ: הַשְׁקִיפָה מִמְּעוֹן קָדְשְׁךָ
מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם[ii] וּבָרֵךְ אֶת עַמְּךָ אֶת
יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאֶת הָאֲדָמָה אֲשֶׁר נָתָתָה
לָנוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּעְתָּ לַאֲבֹתֵינוּ אֶרֶץ
זָבַת חָלָב וּדְבָשׁ:[iii] וְשָׂמַחְתָּ בְכָל
הַטּוֹב אֲשֶׁר נָתַן לְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ
וּלְבֵיתֶךָ אַתָּה וְהַלֵּוִי וְהַגֵּר אֲשֶׁר
בְּקִרְבֶּךָ: וּלְתִתְךָ עֶלְיוֹן עַל כָּל
הַגּוֹיִם אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה לְתִהְלָה וּלְשֵׁם
וּלְתִפְאֶרֶת וְלִהְיוֹתְךָ עַם קָדֹשׁ
לַיְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ כַּאֲשֶׁר דִּבֶּר: וּבָאוּ
עָלֶיךָ כָּל הַבְּרָכוֹת הָאֵלֶּה וְהִשִּׂיגֻךָ
כִּי תִשְׁמַע בְּקוֹל יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ:
בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה בָּעִיר וּבָרוּךְ אַתָּה
בַּשָּׂדֶה: בָּרוּךְ פְּרִי בִטְנְךָ וּפְרִי
אַדְמָתְךָ וּפְרִי בְהֶמְתֶּךָ שְׁגַר אֲלָפֶיךָ
וְעַשְׁתְּרוֹת צֹאנֶךָ:[iv] בָּרוּךְ טַנְאֲךָ
וּמִשְׁאַרְתֶּךָ:[v]

We cried out to the LORD, God of our fathers, and the LORD heard our voice and saw our affliction, 1765R
our toil, and our oppression. Look down from Your holy dwelling, from heaven,[A] and bless Your people Israel and the soil that You have given us, as You swore to our fathers—a land flowing with milk and honey.[1] You shall rejoice in all the good that the 1770R
LORD your God has given to you and to your household, you and the Levite and the stranger who is in your midst. And to make you highest above all the nations[B] that He has made, for praise, for renown, and for glory, and for you to be a holy people to the 1775R
LORD your God, as He has spoken. And all these blessings shall come upon you and overtake you,[2] if you obey the voice of the LORD your God. Blessed shall you be in the city, and blessed shall you be in the field. Blessed shall be the fruit of your womb, 1780R
the fruit of your ground, and the fruit of your livestock, the increase of your cattle and the young of your flock.[3] Blessed shall be your basket and your kneading bowl.

[A] Or: "Gaze down from Your holy habitation in heaven" — This alternative captures the formal, reverential tone of the Hebrew with 'habitation' instead of 'dwelling,' which might better reflect the liturgical context. However, the original translation is more direct and accessible.

[B] Or: "And to set you supreme over all the nations" — This alternative uses 'supreme' to capture the elevated status implied by 'elyon' (highest/supreme), which has theological resonance in Jewish mystical thought. However, 'highest' in the original translation is more literal and directly tied to the Hebrew.

[1] This familiar biblical phrase refers to the abundance and fertility of the Promised Land. In the context of a prayer for healing, it metaphorically represents the restoration to a state of wholeness and prosperity that the sick person seeks.

[2] The Hebrew 'v'hisigucha' (and overtake you) presents the striking image of blessings actively pursuing the faithful, suggesting that divine favor will find the righteous even if they cannot actively seek it—a comforting thought for the bedridden or severely ill.

[3] The Hebrew terms 'shegar alafecha' and 'ashterot tzonecha' specifically refer to newborn livestock, emphasizing not just possession but growth and renewal—themes particularly relevant to prayer for recovery from illness.

[i] This opening verse establishes the efficacy of prayer in times of distress, emphasizing that God hears the cries of the suffering. It serves as a powerful beginning for a prayer sequence directed toward healing.

[ii] The Hebrew word 'hashkifah' (look down) typically carries negative connotations in biblical usage, except when paired with 'mimaon kodshecha' (from Your holy dwelling), where it transforms into a request for divine blessing, as noted in rabbinic interpretation.

[iii] The appeal to God's sworn promise connects the supplicant's request to divine covenant obligations, strengthening the prayer by reminding God of His own commitments.

[iv] The terms 'shegar alafecha' and 'ashterot tzonecha' are specialized terms for newborn cattle and sheep respectively, representing fertility and increase—metaphorically applicable to recovery and renewal of health.

[v] Cf. Deuteronomy 26:7 — This opening verse from the Israelite's declaration upon bringing first fruits establishes a theological foundation that God responds to prayer, particularly in times of distress. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves as a powerful opening for a prayer sequence for the sick,

(נביאים) לְכוּ וְנָשׁוּבָה אֶל
יְיָ כִּי הוּא טָרָף וְיִרְפָּאֵנוּ יַךְ
וַיַּחְבְּשֵׁנוּ: יְחַיֵּנוּ מִיָּמִים בַּיּוֹם
הַשְּׁלִישִׁי יְקִמֵנוּ וְנִחְיֶה לְפָנָיו:
וְנֵדְעָה נִרְדְּפָה לָדַעַת אֶת יְהוָה
כְּשַׁחַר נָכוֹן מוֹצָאוֹ וְיָבוֹא כַגֶּשֶׁם
לָנוּ כְּמַלְקוֹשׁ יוֹרֶה אָרֶץ: אֶהְיֶה
כַטַּל לְיִשְׂרָאֵל יִפְרַח כַּשּׁוֹשַׁנָּה
וְיַךְ שָׁרָשָׁיו כַּלְּבָנוֹן: וְקִרְעוּ
לְבַבְכֶם וְאַל בִּגְדֵיכֶם וְשׁוּבוּ אֶל
יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם כִּי חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם הוּא
אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וְרַב חֶסֶד וְנִחָם עַל
הָרָעָה: נִחַם יְיָ עַל וֹאת לֹא תִהְיֶה
אָמַר יְיָ: וַאֲכַלְתֶּם אָכוֹל וְשָׂבוֹעַ
וְהִלַּלְתֶּם אֶת שֵׁם יְיָ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם אֲשֶׁר
עָשָׂה עִמָּכֶם לְהַפְלִיא וְלֹא יֵבֹשׁוּ
עַמִּי לְעוֹלָם: קָרָאתִי מִצָּרָה לִי
אֶל יְיָ וַיַּעֲנֵנִי מֶמֶּטֶן שְׁאוֹל שִׁוַּעְתִּי

Come, let us return to the LORD, for He has 1785R
torn[A] but He will heal us;[1] He has struck but He
will bind our wounds. He will revive us after two
days; on the third day He will raise us up, and we
shall live before Him. Let us know, let us pursue
knowledge of the LORD; His going forth is as certain 1790R
as the dawn;[B] and He will come to us like the rain,
like the latter rain that waters the earth.[2] I will be
like dew to Israel; he will blossom like the lily, and
strike his roots like Lebanon.[C] Rend your hearts and
not your garments, and return to the LORD your 1795R
God, for He is gracious and compassionate,[D] slow
to anger, abounding in kindness, and relenting of
evil.[3] The LORD has relented concerning this; it
shall not be, says the LORD. You shall eat in plenty
and be satisfied, and you shall praise the name of 1800R
the LORD your God who has dealt wondrously with
you; and My people shall never be put to shame.[4] I

[A] Or: "wounded" — The Hebrew טָרָף can be translated as either 'torn' or 'wounded.' While 'torn' is more literal and carries the vivid imagery of being rent apart, 'wounded' might be more immediately comprehensible in modern English when referring to divine chastisement that leads to healing.

[B] Or: "His appearance is as established as the dawn" — The Hebrew נָכוֹן can mean 'established,' 'certain,' or 'prepared,' while מוֹצָאוֹ can refer to 'going forth' or 'appearance.' This alternate translation emphasizes the reliability and predictability of divine revelation rather than movement.

[C] Or: "and cast his roots like Lebanon" — The Hebrew verb וְיַךְ in this context refers to sending forth or extending roots rather than striking in a violent sense. 'Cast' might better convey the image of roots spreading outward and downward with strength and stability.

[D] Or: "for He is gracious and merciful" — The Hebrew רַחוּם is often translated as 'merciful' in liturgical contexts, particularly in this formula of divine attributes. While 'compassionate' conveys the emotional aspect well, 'merciful' has a stronger connection to the traditional liturgical rendering of these divine attributes.

[1] This compilation of prophetic verses begins with Hosea 6:1-3, which establishes the theological framework that divine chastisement is purposeful and leads to restoration. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's approach to illness as spiritual purification rather than mere punishment.

[2] The metaphors of rain and dew emphasize divine blessing coming from above, representing how divine healing flows downward to those below. This pattern of divine energy descending from higher realms to lower ones is a key concept in the kabbalistic worldview of Ma'avar Yabok.

[3] This section from Joel 2:13 emphasizes divine mercy and forgiveness when approached with sincere repentance, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on confession (vidui) as essential for the sick person's spiritual and physical healing.

[4] This verse from Joel 2:26 shifts from individual healing to communal restoration, suggesting that

affirming that God hears the cries of the suffering. | Cf. Deuteronomy 26:15 — This verse completes the spiritual movement begun in the first verse—from crying out in distress to receiving divine blessing. For the sick person, it offers hope that their prayers will be answered with blessing from God's heavenly dwelling. | Cf. Deuteronomy 26:11 — This verse emphasizes the communal aspect of blessing and joy, suggesting that recovery from illness should be celebrated with others, including religious leaders and community members, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on communal support during illness. | Cf. Deuteronomy 28:2-5 — These verses from the blessings in Deuteronomy establish that divine favor comes through obedience to God's commands. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, they remind the sick person that healing is connected to spiritual alignment with divine will, encouraging both prayer and proper religious observance.

שָׁמַעְתָּ קוֹלִי:[i]

called to the LORD in my distress, and He answered me; from the belly of Sheol[A] I cried out, and You heard my voice.[1] 1805R

(תהלים) שׁוּבִי נַפְשִׁי לִמְנוּחָיְכִי כִּי
יְיָ גָּמַל עָלָיְכִי:[ii] כִּי חִלַּצְתָּ נַפְשִׁי
1625 מִמָּוֶת אֶת עֵינִי מִן דִּמְעָה אֶת רַגְלִי
מִדֶּחִי: כּוֹס יְשׁוּעוֹת אֶשָּׂא[iii] וּבְשֵׁם
יְיָ אֶקְרָא: כִּי גָבַר עָלֵינוּ חַסְדּוֹ
וֶאֱמֶת יְיָ לְעוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ: יֹאמְרוּ
נָא בֵית אַהֲרֹן כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ:
1630 יְיָ לִי לֹא אִירָא מַה יַּעֲשֶׂה לִי
אָדָם: יְיָ לִי בְּעֹזְרָי וַאֲנִי אֶרְאֶה
בְשֹׂנְאָי: סָבּוּנִי כִדְבוֹרִים דֹּעֲכוּ
כְּאֵשׁ קוֹצִים[iv] בְּשֵׁם יְיָ כִּי אֲמִילַם:

(Psalms) Return, O my soul, to your rest,[2] for the LORD has dealt bountifully with you. For You have delivered my soul from death, my eyes from tears, my feet from stumbling. I will lift up the cup of salvation[3] and call upon the name of the LORD. For His 1810R lovingkindness has prevailed over us, and the truth of the LORD is forever, Hallelujah. Let the house of Aaron now say, "His lovingkindness endures forever." The LORD is with me; I will not fear. What can man do to me? The LORD is with me among those 1815R who help me; Therefore I shall see the downfall of

[A] Or: "from the depths of the grave" — While 'belly of Sheol' is the most literal translation and preserves the biblical imagery, 'depths of the grave' might be more immediately comprehensible to modern readers unfamiliar with the Hebrew concept of Sheol. However, the original translation better preserves the powerful metaphor from Jonah.

personal recovery is connected to collective redemption. In Ma'avar Yabok, individual healing rituals are frequently placed in the context of Israel's collective salvation.

[1] The compilation concludes with Jonah's testimony of answered prayer from the depths, creating a therapeutic progression from calling out in distress to experiencing divine response. This pattern of moving from distress to deliverance appears consistently in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences.

[2] This opening verse addresses the soul directly, personifying it as a distinct entity that can find rest in God. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this has special resonance for those approaching death, as it suggests the soul's return to its divine source.

[3] While literally referring to a ritual cup used in thanksgiving offerings, in Ma'avar Yabok's context this becomes a powerful metaphor for accepting divine judgment with gratitude, even in times of illness or approaching death.

[i] Cf. Hosea 6:1-3 — These opening verses from Hosea establish the theological framework that illness and suffering can be divinely ordained steps toward healing and restoration. Ma'avar Yabok integrates this perspective throughout its approach to illness as potentially beneficial for spiritual purification. | Cf. Joel 2:13 — This verse emphasizes internal repentance over external display, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's focus on genuine spiritual preparation through confession (vidui) rather than merely ritual observance. | Cf. Joel 2:18-19, 26 — These verses from Joel promise abundance and divine favor following repentance, supporting the book's view that proper spiritual response to suffering leads to restoration. | Cf. Jonah 2:3 — Jonah's testimony of divine rescue from the depths serves as a powerful conclusion, offering hope that even in the most desperate circumstances (like approaching death), sincere prayer can still reach God and receive answer. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's Seder (prayer sequences) — This compilation exemplifies Ma'avar Yabok's technique of creating therapeutic prayer progressions that move from acknowledgment of suffering through expressions of repentance to confidence in divine restoration, matching the pattern found throughout the book's structured prayer sequences.

[ii] The text uses the feminine form 'עָלָיְכִי' (upon you) when addressing the soul (נפש), which is grammatically feminine in Hebrew. This grammatical choice emphasizes the intimate relationship between the person and their soul as a distinct entity being addressed.

[iii] The 'cup of salvation' (כּוֹס יְשׁוּעוֹת) is a ritual reference to the thanksgiving offering in the Temple. In this context of Ma'avar Yabok, it takes on additional significance as a metaphor for accepting both the positive and negative aspects of divine providence, particularly during illness.

[iv] This vivid simile compares the quick defeat of enemies to how quickly a fire of thorns is extinguished. Thorns burn hot and fast but quickly die out, suggesting that the threats to the soul, while initially intense, will be quickly overcome through divine intervention.

דְּחָה דְחִיתַנִי לִנְפֹּל וַיהוָה עֲזָרָנִי:
יְמִין יְיָ רוֹמֵמָה יְמִין יְיָ עֹשָׂה חָיִל:
לֹא אָמוּת כִּי אֶחְיֶה וַאֲסַפֵּר מַעֲשֵׂי
יָהּ: יַסֹּר יִסְּרַנִּי יָהּ וְלַמָּוֶת לֹא
נְתָנָנִי: אֲנָא יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא: אֲנָא
יְיָ הַצְלִיחָה נָּא: אֵלִי אַתָּה וְאוֹדֶךָּ
אֱלֹהַי אֲרוֹמְמֶךָּ: הוֹדוּ לַיְיָ כִּי טוֹב
כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ: אַחֲלַי יִכֹּנוּ
דְרָכַי לִשְׁמֹר חֻקֶּיךָ: בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה
יְיָ לַמְּדֵנִי חֻקֶּיךָ: גַּל עֵינַי וְאַבִּיטָה
נִפְלָאוֹת מִתּוֹרָתֶךָ: דֶּרֶךְ פִּקּוּדֶיךָ
הֲבִינֵנִי וְאָשִׂיחָה בְּנִפְלְאוֹתֶיךָ:
הֲבִינֵנִי וְאֶצְּרָה תוֹרָתֶךָ וְאֶשְׁמְרֶנָּה
בְכָל לֵב: וְאֶשְׁמְרָה תוֹרָתֶךָ תָמִיד
לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד: וַדִּים חֻלִּיצֵנִי עַד
מָאֹד מִתּוֹרָתְךָ לֹא נָטִיתִי: חִלִּיתִי
פָּנֶיךָ בְכָל לֵב חָנֵּנִי כְּאִמְרָתֶךָ:
טוּב טַעַם וָדַעַת לַמְּדֵנִי כִּי
בְמִצְוֹתֶיךָ הֶאֱמָנְתִּי: יְהִי לִבִּי תָמִים
בְּחֻקֶּיךָ לְמַעַן לֹא אֵבוֹשׁ: כָּלְתָה עֵינַי
לְאִמְרָתֶךָ לֵאמֹר מָתַי תְּנַחֲמֵנִי:
לְעוֹלָם לֹא אֶשְׁכַּח פִּקּוּדֶיךָ כִּי בָם
חִיִּיתָנִי: מַאֲבִי הִתְחַכַּמְתַנִי מִצְוֹתֶךָ
כִּי לְעוֹלָם הִיא לִי: נְדִבוֹת פִּי רְצֵה
נָא יְיָ וּמִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ לַמְּדֵנִי: סָמְכֵנִי
כְאִמְרָתֶךָ וְאֶחְיֶה וְאַל תְּבִישֵׁנִי
מִשַּׂבְרִי: עֻשָּׂה עִם עַבְדְּךָ כְחַסְדֶּךָ
וְחֻקֶּיךָ לַמְּדֵנִי: פָּנֶיךָ הָאֵר בְּעַבְדֶּךָ
וְלַמְּדֵנִי אֶת חֻקֶּיךָ: צַר וּמָצוֹק
מְצָאוּנִי מִצְוֹתֶיךָ שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי:[i][ii]

those who hate me. They surrounded me like bees, they were extinguished like a fire of thorns; In the name of the LORD I will surely cut them off. You pushed me violently to fall, but the LORD helped me. The right hand of the LORD is exalted; The right hand of the LORD does valiantly. I shall not die, but live, and recount the works of the LORD. The LORD has severely disciplined me,[1] but He has not given me over to death. Please, O LORD, save now! Please, O LORD, grant success now! You are my God, and I will praise You; My God, I will exalt You. Give thanks to the LORD, for He is good; For His lovingkindness endures forever. Oh, that my ways were directed to keep Your statutes! Blessed are You, O LORD; Teach me Your statutes. Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things from Your Torah. Make me understand the way of Your precepts; So shall I meditate on Your wonders. Give me understanding, that I may observe Your Torah and keep it with all my heart. And I will keep Your Torah continually, forever and ever. The arrogant have utterly scorned me, yet I have not turned aside from Your Torah. I have sought Your face with all my heart; Be gracious to me according to Your word. Teach me good discernment and knowledge, for I have believed in Your commandments. May my heart be blameless in Your statutes, so that I will not be ashamed. My eyes fail with longing for Your word, saying, "When will You comfort me?" I will never forget Your precepts, for through them You have given me life. Your commandments make me wiser than my enemies, for they are ever with me. Please accept the freewill offerings of my mouth, O

1820R 1825R 1830R 1835R 1840R 1845R

[1] This acknowledgment of divine discipline reflects Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that suffering serves a purifying purpose rather than being random misfortune. The emphasis that God 'has not given me over to death' suggests that even severe trials have redemptive value.

[i] The term 'שַׁעֲשֻׁעָי' (my delight) expresses profound joy and comfort found in divine commandments even amidst 'trouble and anguish' (צַר וּמָצוֹק). This juxtaposition is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok's context of approaching death, suggesting that Torah study provides spiritual sustenance even in life's darkest moments.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 116 — These verses from Psalm 116 establish the theme of gratitude for divine rescue from mortal danger, setting a hopeful tone for this prayer sequence. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses serve to comfort the sick or dying person by reminding them of God's past acts of deliverance. | Cf. Psalm 118 — These verses from Psalm 118 express confidence in divine protection despite being surrounded by enemies, which in Ma'avar Yabok would be interpreted as both physical illness and spiritual adversaries that threaten the soul during serious illness or approaching death. | Cf. Psalm 119 — These verses from Psalm 119 shift the focus from physical deliverance to spiritual guidance, suggesting that even in times of illness, engagement with Torah provides comfort and spiritual sustenance. This aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on spiritual preparation during illness.

LORD, and teach me Your judgments. Uphold me according to Your word, that I may live; And do not let me be ashamed of my hope. Deal with Your servant according to Your lovingkindness, and teach me Your statutes. Make Your face shine upon Your servant, and teach me Your statutes. Trouble and anguish have found me, yet Your commandments are my delight.[1]

(כתובים) יְחַלֵּץ עָנִי בְעָנְיוֹ וְיִגֶּל
בַּלַּחַץ אָזְנָם: לֹא יִגְרַע מִצַּדִּיק
עֵינָיו וְאֶת מְלָכִים לַכִּסֵּא וַיּוֹשִׁיבֵם
לָנֶצַח וַיִּגְבָּהוּ: הֵן אֵל יַשְׂגִּיב בְּכֹחוֹ
מִי כָמֹהוּ מוֹרֶה: מִי פָקַד עָלָיו
דַּרְכּוֹ וּמִי אָמַר פָּעַלְתָּ עַוְלָה:
יַרְעֵם אֵל בְּקוֹלוֹ נִפְלָאוֹת עֹשֶׂה
גְּדֹלוֹת וְלֹא נֵדָע: בְּיַד כָּל אָדָם
יַחְתּוֹם לָדַעַת כָּל אֲנְשֵׁי מַעֲשֵׂהוּ:
וְיִמְנַע מֵרָשָׁעִים אוֹרָם וּזְרוֹעַ רָמָה
תִּשָּׁבֵר: הֵן קָלוֹתִי מָה אֲשִׁיבֶךָּ יָדִי
שַׂמְתִּי לְמוֹ פִּי: לִשְׁמַע אֹזֶן שָׁמַעְתִּיךָ
וְעַתָּה עֵינִי רָאָתְךָ: אָתוֹהִי בְּמָה
רַבְרְבִין וְתִמְהוֹהִי בְּמָה תַּקִּיפִין
מַלְכוּתֵהּ מַלְכוּת עָלַם וְשָׁלְטָנֵהּ
עִם דָּר וְדָר: חָזֵה הֲוֵית עַד דִּי
כָרְסָוָן רְמִיו וְעַתִּיק יוֹמִין יְתֵב
לְבוּשֵׁהּ כְּתַלַּג חִוָּר וּשְׂעַר רֵאשֵׁהּ
כַּעֲמַר נְקֵא כָּרְסְיֵהּ שְׁבִיבִין דִּי נוּר
גַּלְגְּלוֹהִי נוּר דָּלִק:[i]

He delivers the poor in their affliction,[A] and opens their ears in oppression. He does not withdraw His eyes from the righteous,[B] but with kings on the throne He establishes them forever, and they are exalted. Behold, God is exalted in His power; who is a teacher like Him? Who has prescribed His way for Him? Or who has said, 'You have done wrong'? God thunders marvelously with His voice; He does great things which we cannot comprehend. For He seals the hand of every person, that all may know His work. He withholds light from the wicked, and the uplifted arm is broken. Behold, I am insignificant; what can I reply to You? I place my hand over my mouth.[2] I have heard of You by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees You. How great are His signs, and how mighty are His wonders! His kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and His dominion is from generation to generation.[3] I was watching until thrones were set up, and the Ancient of Days[C] was seated;[4] His garment was white as

[A] Or: "He rescues the afflicted through their suffering" — This alternate translation emphasizes how suffering itself becomes the vehicle for salvation, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theme that affliction serves as a purifying mechanism rather than merely being relieved.

[B] Or: "He does not diminish His attention from the righteous" — The Hebrew 'יִגְרַע' (yigra) carries connotations of diminishing or lessening, not just withdrawing. This alternate better captures the idea that God maintains full attention on the righteous without any reduction in His watchfulness.

[C] Or: "the Ancient One" — In kabbalistic literature, particularly relevant to Ma'avar Yabok,

[1] The passage concludes with the paradoxical notion that even in 'trouble and anguish,' divine commandments provide delight. This illustrates Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on Torah study as spiritual sustenance during illness, suggesting that engagement with sacred text offers comfort even when physical healing is uncertain.

[2] This gesture symbolizes the silencing of human argumentation when confronted with divine wisdom, representing the ideal posture of acceptance before death that Ma'avar Yabok advocates.

[3] This passage transitions from Hebrew (Job) to Aramaic (Daniel), indicating a compilation of texts that describes a progression from earthly suffering to divine throne vision—mirroring the soul's journey from physical affliction to spiritual revelation.

[4] In kabbalistic tradition, especially relevant to Ma'avar Yabok, 'Ancient of Days' (Atik Yomin)

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, root.7.1.1.1.2.94 — The current passage presents God's sovereign power and judgment, while the section from root.7.1.1.1.2.94 emphasizes divine mercy and healing. These complement each other in Ma'avar Yabok's theology where divine severity and mercy work together in the spiritual journey. | Cf. Daniel 7:9-10 — The final verses of this passage are directly quoted

snow, and the hair of His head like pure wool. His throne was fiery flames, its wheels burning fire.

חֲמוֹל עָלַי וְכַפֵּר מַעֲלָלַי.[i] וְשׁוּר שִׁירִי כְּשִׁיר מוּשִׁי וּמַחְלִי.[ii] וְיוֹם 1685 תָּבִיא יְצוּרֶךָ בְּמִשְׁפָּט. אֱלֹהַי אַל תְּדִינֵנִי כְּמַעֲלַי:[iii iv]

Have mercy upon me and atone for my misdeeds.[1] Look upon my song as the song of Mushi and Machli.[A] And on the day when You bring Your creatures to judgment, my God, do not judge me according to my transgressions.[B] 1880R

מנחה ליום ששי[v]

Afternoon Prayer for Friday[2] 1885R

יאמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[vi] ואח״כ

He should recite the verses beginning with "Ana

'Atik Yomin' is often translated as 'the Ancient One,' referring to a specific divine configuration. This alternate better preserves the technical mystical terminology.

[A] Or: "And regard my song as if it were the song of Mushi and Machli" — This alternate translation emphasizes the hypothetical comparison more clearly, highlighting that the author is asking for his prayer to be elevated to the status of Temple service.

[B] Or: "my God, do not judge me in accordance with my wrongdoing" — This alternate uses 'wrongdoing' instead of 'transgressions' and makes the relationship between judgment and actions more explicit with 'in accordance with.'

refers to a specific divine configuration representing the highest aspect of divine mercy, which tempers the fiery judgment represented by the throne.

[1] This opening follows a traditional Jewish prayer formula requesting divine mercy and forgiveness.

[2] In Jewish tradition, the Friday afternoon prayer (Mincha) has special significance as it immediately precedes the onset of the Sabbath. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this likely introduces prayers or rituals to be performed specifically at this transitional time, which may have particular relevance for the sick or dying.

from Daniel's apocalyptic vision. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this vision would likely be interpreted as a glimpse of the divine judgment that souls face after death, providing a meditation on the awesome nature of the divine presence awaiting the soul. | Cf. Job 36-37 — The first part of this passage comes from Job, where Elihu defends God's justice. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses would support the book's central theological premise that suffering has purpose within divine justice, and that God ultimately exalts the righteous despite their temporary afflictions. | Cf. Job 40:4 and 42:5-6 — The verses 'I am insignificant; what can I reply to You? I place my hand over my mouth' and 'I have heard of You by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees You' come from Job's final surrender to divine wisdom. In Ma'avar Yabok, this represents the ideal spiritual posture before death—humility and surrender that leads to direct divine vision.

[i] The term 'מַעֲלָלַי' (my misdeeds) comes from a root that can suggest both actions generally and evil deeds specifically. Here it clearly refers to sinful actions.

[ii] This is a reference to Mushi and Machli, descendants of Levi who were involved in the Temple musical service. They were sons of Merari (see Numbers 3:20, 1 Chronicles 6:19, 23:21-23). The author is asking God to view his prayer-song with the same favor as the Temple music offered by these Levites.

[iii] There is wordplay between 'מַעֲלָלַי' (my misdeeds) earlier in the prayer and 'כְּמַעֲלַי' (according to my transgressions) here, creating a poetic resonance.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 51:1-2 — The opening follows the pattern of penitential psalms, particularly Psalm 51, establishing this as a prayer of confession and request for forgiveness. | Cf. 1 Chronicles 6:19, 23:21-23 — By invoking these Levitical musicians, the author suggests his prayer should be received like Temple service, elevating his personal supplication to ritual significance. | Cf. Psalm 143:2 — The closing line echoes this psalm's acknowledgment that no human could withstand divine judgment based solely on their actions, thus requiring divine mercy.

[v] This is a heading indicating that what follows is the Mincha (afternoon prayer) service specifically for Friday, which is particularly significant as it marks the transition toward the Sabbath.

[vi] These are specific opening verses beginning with "Ana Hashem" (Please, O LORD) that appear consistently throughout Ma'avar Yabok as the standard opening for each prayer sequence.

יתחיל מזמור חלצני ה׳ וגומר תהלים סימן ק״מ[i] סדר ח[ii] ואח״כ יאמר זה:

Hashem"[1] (Please, O LORD), and afterward begin Psalm 140, "Deliver me, O LORD" and complete it, then Order 8,[2] and afterward recite this:

(תורה) בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה בְּבֹאֶךָ וּבָרוּךְ אַתָּה בְּצֵאתֶךָ: יִתֵּן יְיָ אֶת אֹיְבֶיךָ הַקָּמִים עָלֶיךָ נִגָּפִים לְפָנֶיךָ בְּדֶרֶךְ אֶחָד יֵצְאוּ אֵלֶיךָ וּבְשִׁבְעָה דְרָכִים יָנוּסוּ לְפָנֶיךָ:[iii] יְצַו יְיָ אִתְּךָ אֶת הַבְּרָכָה בַּאֲסָמֶיךָ וּבְכֹל מִשְׁלַח יָדֶךָ וּבֵרַכְךָ בָּאָרֶץ אֲשֶׁר יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ נֹתֵן לָךְ: וְרָאוּ כָּל עַמֵּי הָאָרֶץ כִּי שֵׁם יְיָ נִקְרָא עָלֶיךָ וְיָרְאוּ מִמֶּךָּ: יִפְתַּח יְיָ לְךָ אֶת אוֹצָרוֹ הַטּוֹב[iv] אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם לָתֵת מְטַר אַרְצְךָ בְּעִתּוֹ וּלְבָרֵךְ אֶת כָּל מַעֲשֵׂה יָדֶךָ וְהִלְוִיתָ גּוֹיִם רַבִּים וְאַתָּה לֹא תִלְוֶה: וּנְתָנְךָ יְיָ לְרֹאשׁ וְלֹא לְזָנָב וְהָיִיתָ רַק לְמַעְלָה וְלֹא תִהְיֶה לְמָטָּה כִּי תִשְׁמַע אֶל מִצְוֹת יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מְצַוְּךָ הַיּוֹם לִשְׁמֹר וְלַעֲשׂוֹת: וְשָׁבְתָּ[v] עַד יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ וְשָׁמַעְתָּ בְקֹלוֹ כְּכֹל אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מְצַוְּךָ הַיּוֹם

(Torah) Blessed shall you be when you come in, and blessed shall you be when you go out. The LORD will cause your enemies who rise against you to be defeated before you;[3] they shall come out against you one way and flee before you seven ways.[A] The LORD will command the blessing upon you in your storehouses and in all that you undertake; He will bless you in the land that the LORD your God is giving you. Then all the peoples of the earth shall see that the name of the LORD is proclaimed over you, and they shall fear you. The LORD will open for you His good treasury, the heavens,[B] to give the rain of your land in its season and to bless all the work of your hands. You shall lend to many nations, but you shall not borrow. The LORD will make you the head and not the tail; you shall be only above and not beneath,[4] if you obey the commandments of the LORD your God, which I command you today, by being careful to observe them. And you shall 1890R 1895R 1900R 1905R

[A] Or: "they will march against you in a single formation but scatter in seven directions before you" — This more vivid translation better captures the military imagery of the original Hebrew, which contrasts the organized approach of enemies with their chaotic, complete retreat.

[B] Or: "The LORD will unlock for you His good storehouse, the heavens" — The verb 'unlock' and noun 'storehouse' might better convey the imagery of a divine vault being opened to release blessings, which aligns with the subsequent imagery of rain coming from this celestial treasury.

[1] These opening verses form a standard pattern in Ma'avar Yabok, where each prayer sequence begins with verses starting with "Ana Hashem" (Please, O LORD). This creates ritual continuity throughout the book's prayer sequences.

[2] The Hebrew "Seder 8" (סדר ח) likely refers to continuing with the eighth standardized prayer sequence. I've maintained the term "Order" to preserve the sense that this refers to a specific, established liturgical sequence rather than simply the next step in the instructions.

[3] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these "enemies" would be understood metaphorically as illness, the Angel of Death, or negative spiritual forces that threaten the sick person.

[4] This spatial metaphor of being "above and not beneath" would be interpreted in the prayer context as referring to spiritual elevation rather than merely social status.

[i] Psalm 140, which begins "Deliver me, O LORD" (חלצני ה׳), focuses on themes of divine protection from enemies and harmful speech, making it particularly appropriate in the context of prayers for the sick or dying who might feel vulnerable to both physical affliction and spiritual attack.

[ii] This refers to the eighth liturgical sequence (Seder Het) in Ma'avar Yabok's system of prayers for the sick and dying. Each "seder" follows a similar structure with opening prayers, psalms, biblical verses, and concluding prayers.

[iii] The number seven represents completeness in Jewish tradition. The image of enemies fleeing in seven directions symbolizes total defeat of all spiritual obstacles or illnesses.

[iv] The concept of heaven as God's "good treasury" (otzaro hatov) is significant in kabbalistic thought, representing the divine source from which all blessings flow.

[v] The Hebrew verb "v'shavta" (you shall return) shares the same root as "teshuvah" (repentance). This emphasizes that healing requires spiritual return to God, not merely physical recovery.

אַתָּה וּבָנֶיךָ בְּכָל לְבָבְךָ וּבְכָל
נַפְשֶׁךָ: וְשָׁב יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֶת שְׁבוּתְךָ
וְרִחֲמֶךָ וְשָׁב וְקִבֶּצְךָ מִכָּל הָעַמִּים
1715 [i] אֲשֶׁר הֱפִיצְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ שָׁמָּה:

return to the LORD your God and obey His voice according to all that I command you today, you and 1910R
your children, with all your heart and with all your soul. Then the LORD your God will restore your fortunes and have compassion on you,[1] returning to gather you from all the peoples among whom the LORD your God has scattered you. 1915R

(נביאים) בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי נַפְשִׁי אֶת
יְהוָה זָכָרְתִּי וַתָּבוֹא אֵלֶיךָ תְּפִלָּתִי
אֶל הֵיכַל קָדְשֶׁךָ: כִּי כָל הָעַמִּים
יֵלְכוּ אִישׁ בְּשֵׁם אֱלֹהָיו וַאֲנַחְנוּ
1720 נֵלֵךְ בְּשֵׁם יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ לְעוֹלָם
וָעֶד: תָּרֹם יָדְךָ עַל צָרֶיךָ וְכָל
אוֹיְבֶיךָ יִכָּרֵתוּ: וַאֲנִי בַיהוָה אֲצַפֶּה
אוֹחִילָה לֵאלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי יִשְׁמָעֵנִי
אֱלֹהָי: אַל תִּשְׂמְחִי אֹיַבְתִּי לִי כִּי
1725 נָפַלְתִּי קָמְתִּי כִּי אֵשֵׁב בַּחֹשֶׁךְ יְיָ
אוֹר לִי: זַעַף יְיָ אֶשָּׂא כִּי חָטָאתִי
לוֹ עַד אֲשֶׁר יָרִיב רִיבִי וְעָשָׂה
מִשְׁפָּטִי יוֹצִיאֵנִי לָאוֹר אֶרְאֶה
בְּצִדְקָתוֹ: [ii] יִרְאוּ גוֹיִם וְיֵבֹשׁוּ מִכֹּל

(Prophets) When my soul fainted within me,[A] I remembered the LORD, and my prayer came to You, to Your holy temple. For all peoples will walk each in the name of his god, but we will walk in the name of the LORD our God forever and ever.[2] May Your 1920R
hand be lifted up against Your adversaries, and may all Your enemies be cut off. But as for me, I will watch expectantly for the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation. My God will hear me. Do not rejoice over me, O my enemy. Though I have fallen, 1925R
I will rise; though I sit in darkness, the LORD is a light to me.[3] I will bear the indignation of the LORD[B] because I have sinned against Him, until He pleads my case[C] and executes justice for me. He will

[A] Or: "When my soul was overwhelmed within me" — The Hebrew word 'hit'atef' has connotations of being wrapped up, covered, or overwhelmed rather than just fainting. This translation captures the sense of spiritual distress more accurately.

[B] Or: "I will bear the LORD's wrath" — The term 'za'af' specifically refers to anger or wrath, though 'indignation' is a good literary translation. The alternate is more direct and maintains the emotional intensity.

[C] Or: "He contends for my cause" — The repetition in Hebrew (yariv rivi) creates a stronger sense of advocacy through legal contention. This translation better captures the forceful legal metaphor.

[1] The Hebrew term "shevutekha" (your fortunes/captivity) plays on the earlier use of "v'shavta" (you shall return), creating a reciprocal relationship: when you return to God, God returns your well-being.

[2] This declaration of communal faithfulness from Micah 4:5 creates a contrast between temporary personal suffering and eternal divine commitment, offering spiritual perspective to the sick or dying person.

[3] This verse creates a therapeutic progression typical in Ma'avar Yabok's prayer sequences, moving from acknowledgment of suffering to affirmation of divine presence even in darkness. The light metaphor would be particularly meaningful in the context of deathbed prayers.

[i] Cf. Deuteronomy 28:6-9, 12-13 — This passage compiles several verses from the blessing section of Deuteronomy 28, which promises prosperity, protection, and prominence to Israel if they follow God's commandments. In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses create a protective shield of divine blessing for the sick person through the power of scriptural recitation. | Cf. Deuteronomy 30:2-3 — These concluding verses shift the focus to repentance and restoration, offering hope that even after punishment or suffering, returning to God with sincerity will bring divine compassion and gathering of the scattered. In the context of illness, this suggests that sincere repentance can lead to healing and restoration.

[ii] This metaphor of being brought from darkness to light appears throughout the biblical text as a symbol of divine deliverance and spiritual renewal. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it would resonate with the sick or dying person's hope for spiritual enlightenment and divine mercy.

וּגְבוּרָתָם יָשִׂימוּ יָד עַל פֶּה אָזְנֵיהֶם
תֶּחֱרַשְׁנָה: מִי אֵל כָּמוֹךָ[i] נֹשֵׂא עָוֹן
וְעֹבֵר עַל פֶּשַׁע לִשְׁאֵרִית נַחֲלָתוֹ
לֹא הֶחֱזִיק לָעַד אַפּוֹ כִּי חָפֵץ חֶסֶד
הוּא: [ii]

bring me out to the light, and I will see His righteousness. Then my enemies will see and be ashamed of all their might; they will put their hand over their mouth, their ears will become deaf. Who is a God like You, who pardons iniquity and passes over the rebellious act of the remnant of His possession? He does not retain His anger forever, because He delights in mercy.[1]

(תהלים) קוֹלִי שִׁמְעָה כְחַסְדֶּךָ
יְיָ כְּמִשְׁפָּטֶךָ חַיֵּנִי: רִיבָה רִיבִי
וּגְאָלֵנִי לְאִמָרָתְךָ חַיֵּנִי: שִׁבַּרְתִּי
לִישׁוּעָתְךָ יְיָ וּמִצְוֹתֶיךָ עָשִׂיתִי:
תְּחִי נַפְשִׁי וּתְהַלְלֶךָּ וּמִשְׁפָּטֶךָ
יַעְזְרֵנִי: יְיָ הַצִּילָה נַפְשִׁי מִשְּׂפַת
שֶׁקֶר מִלָּשׁוֹן רְמִיָּה:[iii] עֶזְרִי מֵעִם יְיָ
עֹשֵׂה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ: אַל יִתֵּן לַמּוֹט
רַגְלֶךָ אַל יָנוּם שֹׁמְרֶךָ: יְיָ יִשְׁמָרְךָ
מִכָּל רָע יִשְׁמֹר אֶת נַפְשֶׁךָ:[iv] יְיָ
יִשְׁמָר צֵאתְךָ וּבוֹאֶךָ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד
עוֹלָם: יְיָ שָׁלוֹם בְּחֵילֶךָ שַׁלְוָה
בְּאַרְמְנוֹתָיִךְ: הִנֵּה כְעֵינֵי עֲבָדִים
אֶל יַד אֲדוֹנֵיהֶם כְּעֵינֵי שִׁפְחָה
אֶל יַד גְּבִרְתָּהּ כֵּן עֵינֵינוּ אֶל
יְיָ אֱלֹהֵינוּ עַד שֶׁיְּחָנֵנוּ: חָנֵנוּ יְיָ
חָנֵנוּ כִּי רַב שָׂבַעְנוּ בוּז: לוּלֵי

(Psalms) Hear my voice according to Your loving-kindness, O LORD; revive me according to Your justice. Champion my cause and redeem me; give me life according to Your word. I have hoped for Your salvation, O LORD, and I have fulfilled Your commandments. May my soul live and praise You,[A] and may Your judgments sustain me. O LORD, deliver my soul from lying lips, from a deceitful tongue. My help comes from the LORD, maker of heaven and earth. He will not allow your foot to slip; your guardian will not slumber. The LORD will guard you from all evil; He will protect your soul. The LORD will guard your going out and your coming in, from now and forever. May there be peace within your walls, tranquility in your palaces. Behold, as the eyes of servants look to the hand of their masters, as the eyes of a maidservant to the hand of

[A] Or: "Let my soul be revived so that it may praise You" — This translation more explicitly connects the revival of the soul with its subsequent ability to praise God, highlighting the theological principle in Ma'avar Yabok that the purpose of healing and life is divine service and praise.

[1] The prayer concludes with an emphasis on God's merciful nature rather than judgment, following Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theological framework that views divine mercy as ultimately prevailing over judgment, even in death.

[i] This rhetorical question forms a wordplay on the name 'Micah' (מִיכָה) itself, which means 'Who is like [God]?' The verse affirms the incomparability of God particularly in His capacity for forgiveness and mercy.

[ii] Cf. Jonah 2:7 — This quotation establishes a theme of spiritual distress followed by divine remembrance and deliverance that runs throughout this prayer passage. | Cf. Micah 4:5 — The inclusion of this verse in the prayer text connects individual suffering with communal faithfulness, suggesting that the individual's distress and hope are grounded in their identity as part of God's covenant people. | Cf. Micah 7:7-10 — The use of this passage transforms individual suffering into a spiritual journey from distress through confession to divine vindication, offering comfort to the sick or dying person by placing their suffering within a redemptive narrative. | Cf. Micah 7:18 — The prayer concludes with this powerful affirmation of God's merciful nature, emphasizing divine forgiveness over punishment. This would be particularly meaningful in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where the sick or dying person is seeking divine mercy and forgiveness.

[iii] The theme of deliverance from 'deceitful tongues' has particular significance in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, as the dying were considered especially vulnerable to spiritual accusers (mekatregim) whose 'deceitful tongues' could impede the soul's peaceful journey.

[iv] The repeated emphasis on protecting the 'nefesh' (soul) reflects the book's primary concern with safeguarding the soul during its transition from this world to the next.

יְיָ שֶׁהָיָה לָנוּ בְּקוּם עָלֵינוּ אָדָם:
אֲזַי חַיִּים בְּלָעוּנוּ בַּחֲרוֹת אַפָּם
בָּנוּ: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ שֶׁלֹּא נְתָנָנוּ טֶרֶף
לְשִׁנֵּיהֶם: נַפְשֵׁנוּ כְּצִפּוֹר נִמְלָטָה
מִפַּח יוֹקְשִׁים[i] הַפַּח נִשְׁבָּר וַאֲנַחְנוּ
נִמְלָטְנוּ: עֶזְרֵנוּ בְּשֵׁם יְיָ עֹשֵׂה
שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ: הֵיטִיבָה יְיָ לַטּוֹבִים
וְלִישָׁרִים בְּלִבּוֹתָם: הַזֹּרְעִים
בְּדִמְעָה בְּרִנָּה יִקְצֹרוּ: שָׁוְא לָכֶם
מַשְׁכִּימֵי קוּם מְאַחֲרֵי שֶׁבֶת אֹכְלֵי
לֶחֶם הָעֲצָבִים כֵּן יִתֵּן לִידִידוֹ
שֵׁנָא: יְבָרֶכְךָ יְהוָה מִצִּיּוֹן וּרְאֵה
בְּטוּב יְרוּשָׁלַם כֹּל יְמֵי חַיֶּיךָ: יְיָ
צַדִּיק קִצֵּץ עֲבוֹת רְשָׁעִים: קִוִּיתִי
יְיָ קִוְּתָה נַפְשִׁי וְלִדְבָרוֹ הוֹחָלְתִּי:
יַחֵל יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶל יְיָ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד
עוֹלָם: אוֹיְבָיו אַלְבִּישׁ בֹּשֶׁת וְעָלָיו
יָצִיץ נִזְרוֹ: כִּי שָׁם צִוָּה יְיָ אֶת
הַבְּרָכָה חַיִּים עַד הָעוֹלָם: יְבָרֶכְךָ
יְיָ מִצִּיּוֹן עֹשֵׂה שָׁמַיִם וָאָרֶץ: בֵּית
יִשְׂרָאֵל בָּרֲכוּ אֶת יְהוָה בֵּית אַהֲרֹן
בָּרֲכוּ אֶת יְהוָה: בֵּית הַלֵּוִי בָּרֲכוּ
אֶת יְהוָה יִרְאֵי יְהוָה בָּרֲכוּ אֶת
יְהוָה: בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה מִצִּיּוֹן שֹׁכֵן
יְרוּשָׁלַם הַלְלוּיָהּ: נֹתֵן לֶחֶם לְכָל
בָּשָׂר כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ: [ii] הוֹדוּ
לְאֵל הַשָּׁמַיִם כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ: אִם

her mistress,[1] so our eyes look to the LORD our 1955R
God, until He is gracious to us. Be gracious to us,
O LORD, be gracious to us, for we have endured
much contempt. Had not the LORD been with us
when people rose up against us, then they would have
swallowed us alive in their burning anger against 1960R
us. Blessed is the LORD, who has not given us
as prey to their teeth. Our soul has escaped like
a bird from the hunter's snare; the snare is broken,
and we have escaped.[2] Our help is in the name of
the LORD, maker of heaven and earth. Do good, 1965R
O LORD, to the good, to those upright in their
hearts. Those who sow in tears will reap with songs
of joy. It is futile for you to rise early, to stay up late,
eating the bread of toil;[A] for He gives to His beloved
sleep.[3] May the LORD bless you from Zion; may you 1970R
see the prosperity of Jerusalem all the days of your
life. The LORD is righteous; He has cut the cords
of the wicked. I wait for the LORD, my soul waits,
and in His word I place my hope. Let Israel hope
in the LORD[B] from now and forever. His enemies 1975R
I will clothe with shame, but upon him his crown
will shine. For there the LORD has commanded the
blessing—life forevermore. May the LORD bless you
from Zion, He who made heaven and earth. O house
of Israel, bless the LORD; O house of Aaron, bless 1980R
the LORD; O house of Levi, bless the LORD; you

[A] Or: "to rise early, to sit up late, consuming the bread of sorrows" — The Hebrew 'lechem ha-atzavim' could be translated more literally as 'bread of sorrows' rather than 'bread of toil,' emphasizing the emotional rather than physical dimension of labor. This alternate translation might better convey the contrast with the peaceful sleep given to God's beloved.

[B] Or: "Let Israel wait expectantly for the LORD" — The Hebrew verb 'yachel' has connotations of waiting with expectation and patience, not merely hoping. This nuance could be important in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, where both the ill person and mourners are encouraged to wait patiently for divine deliverance rather than merely hoping for it.

[1] This simile expresses the ideal spiritual posture of complete dependence on God, particularly relevant for the sick and dying who must surrender to divine will while maintaining hope for mercy.

[2] In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this image of liberation from the snare would be understood as both physical healing from illness and the soul's liberation from bodily constraints at death.

[3] The Hebrew 'sheina' (sleep) can also be read as a play on words with the similar sounding 'shana' (change/transformation), suggesting that God grants His beloved transformation through difficult circumstances.

[i] This powerful metaphor of the bird escaping the snare would be understood in the context of Ma'avar Yabok as the soul's liberation from both physical suffering and spiritual entrapments that might impede its journey after death.

[ii] The emphasis on God's eternal loving-kindness (chesed) at the conclusion of this prayer sequence balances the earlier references to divine justice (mishpat), reflecting the kabbalistic understanding that mercy ultimately tempers judgment.

[i] אֶשְׁכָּחֵךְ יְרוּשָׁלָם תִּשְׁכַּח יְמִינִי׃

who fear the LORD, bless the LORD. Blessed be the LORD from Zion, who dwells in Jerusalem. Hallelujah! He gives food to all flesh, for His loving-kindness endures forever. Give thanks to the God of heaven, 1985R
for His loving-kindness endures forever. If I forget you, O Jerusalem, let my right hand forget its skill.[1]

(כתובים) נְהַר דִּי נוּר נָגֵד
וְנָפֵק מִן קֳדָמוֹהִי[ii] אֶלֶף אַלְפִין
יְשַׁמְּשׁוּנֵּהּ וְרִבּוֹ רִבְבָן קָדָמוֹהִי
יְקוּמוּן דִּינָא יְתִב וְסִפְרִין
פְּתִיחוּ׃ אֲנָא אֲדֹנָי הָאֵל הַגָּדוֹל
וְהַנּוֹרָא[iii] שֹׁמֵר הַבְּרִית וְהַחֶסֶד
לְאֹהֲבָיו וּלְשֹׁמְרֵי מִצְוֹתָיו חָטָאנוּ
וְעָוִינוּ הִרְשַׁעְנוּ וּמָרַדְנוּ וְסוֹר
מִמִּצְוֹתֶךָ וּמִמִּשְׁפָּטֶיךָ׃[iv] יְיָ לָנוּ
בֹּשֶׁת הַפָּנִים[v] לְמָלְכֵינוּ לְשָׂרֵינוּ
וְלַאֲבוֹתֵינוּ אֲשֶׁר חָטָאנוּ לָךְ׃ לַאדֹנָי
אֱלֹהֵינוּ הָרַחֲמִים וְהַסְּלִיחוֹת כִּי

(Writings) A stream of fire flowed forth from before Him;[A] a thousand thousands served Him, and ten thousand times ten thousand stood before 1990R
Him. The judgment was set and the books were opened.[2] Please, O Lord, the great and awesome God, who keeps the covenant and loving-kindness for those who love Him and keep His commandments— we have sinned, we have transgressed, we have acted 1995R
wickedly, and we have rebelled,[3] turning away from Your commandments and Your ordinances. O Lord, to us belongs shame of face, to our kings, to our princes, and to our fathers,[B] for we have sinned

[A] Or: "A river of fire issued and came forth from before Him" — This alternative translation is more literal and preserves the Aramaic construction more directly. It might be preferred in contexts requiring more formal equivalence to the source text.

[B] Or: "O Lord, we bear the disgrace—we, our kings, our officials, and our ancestors" — This

[1] This final verse from Psalm 137:5 seems unconnected to the previous themes, but in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, Jerusalem represents both the earthly holy city and its heavenly counterpart—the ultimate destination of the righteous soul. The promise never to forget Jerusalem thus becomes a pledge of spiritual fidelity even in the face of death.

[2] In Jewish tradition, these "books" refer to the divine records of human deeds that are consulted during judgment, particularly emphasized during the High Holy Days.

[3] This sequence (חָטָאנוּ וְעָוִינוּ הִרְשַׁעְנוּ וּמָרַדְנוּ) forms a classic formula in Jewish confession (vidui), each term representing an increasingly severe level of wrongdoing.

[i] Cf. Psalms — This compilation draws verses from numerous psalms to create a cohesive prayer seeking divine protection, expressing trust in God's salvation, and praising His eternal mercy. The selection particularly emphasizes themes of divine guardianship, deliverance from enemies, and blessing from Zion—all concepts that would offer comfort to someone facing illness or approaching death. | Cf. Zohar — The compilation of these psalm verses, particularly those from Psalm 121 about divine guardianship, connects to Zoharic teachings about the soul's protection during transitions and times of vulnerability. The reference to the broken snare (Psalm 124:7) would be interpreted in kabbalistic thought as the soul's liberation from physical and spiritual constraints. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This compilation follows the pattern established in earlier sections of Ma'avar Yabok, where biblical verses (particularly from Psalms) are arranged to create a therapeutic spiritual progression from expressions of distress to declarations of confidence in divine salvation. This structured approach is consistent with the book's methodology of creating healing prayers through carefully selected scriptural passages.

[ii] This opening verse is from Daniel 7:10, part of Daniel's vision of the Ancient of Days. It's written in Aramaic rather than Hebrew, as is much of the Book of Daniel.

[iii] This begins a confessional prayer drawing heavily from biblical sources, particularly Daniel 9:4-19, which forms the basis for many Jewish confessional prayers.

[iv] The confession follows a pattern common in Jewish liturgy, beginning with general acknowledgments of sin followed by more specific admissions.

[v] This phrase from Daniel 9:8 acknowledges the collective shame of the entire community, including leaders and ancestors, emphasizing the communal nature of confession in Jewish tradition.

מָרַדְנוּ בוֹ: אֲדֹנָי שִׁמְעָה אֲדֹנָי
סְלָחָה אֲדֹנָי הַקְשִׁיבָה[i] וַעֲשֵׂה אַל
תְּאַחַר לְמַעַנְךָ אֱלֹהַי כִּי שִׁמְךָ
1795 נִקְרָא עַל עִירְךָ וְעַל עַמֶּךָ: יְיָ
אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל צַדִּיק אַתָּה כִּי
נִשְׁאַרְנוּ פְלֵיטָה כְּהַיּוֹם הַזֶּה:
אֱלֹהַי בּשְׁתִּי וְנִכְלַמְתִּי לְהָרִים
אֱלֹהַי פָּנַי אֵלֶיךָ: כִּי עֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ
1800 רָבוּ לְמַעְלָה רֹאשׁ[ii] וְאַשְׁמָתֵנוּ
גָדְלָה עַד לַשָּׁמָיִם: וְעַתָּה מַה
נֹּאמַר אֱלֹהֵינוּ אַחֲרֵי זֹאת כִּי
עָזַבְנוּ מִצְוֹתֶיךָ: וְהַמַּשְׂכִּלִים יַזְהִרוּ
כְּזֹהַר הָרָקִיעַ[iii] וּמַצְדִּיקֵי הָרַבִּים
1805 [iv] כַּכּוֹכָבִים לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:

against You. To the Lord our God belong mercy and 2000R
forgiveness, though we have rebelled against Him. O
Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive; O Lord, listen and act!
Do not delay, for Your own sake, my God, for Your
name is called upon Your city and Your people. O
Lord God of Israel, You are righteous, for we remain 2005R
as survivors to this day. My God, I am ashamed and
humiliated to lift up my face to You, my God, for
our iniquities have risen above our heads, and our
guilt has grown up to the heavens.[1] And now, what
shall we say, our God, after this, for we have forsaken 2010R
Your commandments? And those who are wise shall
shine like the brightness of the firmament,[A] and
those who turn many to righteousness[2] like the stars
forever and ever.

בְּשָׁפְכִי חִן לְפָנֶיךָ וַאֲנְחִין.[v] שְׁעֵנִי As I pour out grace before You and sigh,[B] answer 2015R

modernized phrasing might be preferred in contemporary contexts, though it loses some of the biblical resonance of "shame of face" which has specific connotations in traditional Jewish penitential literature.

[A] Or: "And the enlightened ones will radiate like the splendor of the sky" — This alternative captures the mystical connotations of the Hebrew "משכילים" better, as it implies not just intellectual wisdom but spiritual illumination. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this interpretation aligns with kabbalistic concepts of the soul's luminescence after death.

[B] Or: "When I pour out my plea before You with groans" — The term "חִין" could also be

[1] This powerful metaphor suggests sins that have accumulated to such an extent that they reach from earth to heaven, emphasizing both their magnitude and their cosmic significance.

[2] The phrase "מַצְדִּיקֵי הָרַבִּים" (those who make the many righteous) refers to spiritual teachers and leaders who guide others to righteousness. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this relates to those who help others prepare spiritually for death.

[i] This threefold repetition of "Adonai" (Lord) from Daniel 9:19 is particularly intense, creating a crescendo in the prayer's emotional appeal.

[ii] This metaphor from Ezra 9:6 depicts sins as physically towering over one's head, suggesting both their quantity and their spiritual weight.

[iii] This verse from Daniel 12:3 significantly shifts the tone from confession to a vision of ultimate reward for the righteous. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that proper confession and repentance lead to spiritual illumination after death.

[iv] Cf. Daniel 7:10 — The author opens with this powerful image of divine judgment to establish the proper sense of awe before beginning a confessional prayer. This frames the entire confession within the context of standing before the divine tribunal. | Cf. Daniel 9:4-19 — This prayer draws heavily from Daniel's confession, adapting it for personal and communal use when facing death. The structural parallel suggests that just as Daniel sought national redemption through confession, the individual can seek personal redemption when approaching death. | Cf. Ezra 9:6-7 — By incorporating Ezra's language of overwhelming guilt, the author connects personal confession with the historical pattern of Jewish communal repentance in times of crisis. | Cf. Daniel 12:3 — The inclusion of this verse shifts the focus from confession to ultimate reward, suggesting that proper spiritual preparation for death (including thorough confession) leads to celestial radiance in the afterlife. This connects to Ma'avar Yabok's central theme of preparing the soul for its journey after death. | Cf. Yom Kippur liturgy — This prayer adapts the High Holy Day confession for use at the deathbed, suggesting that the approach of death is a time for final atonement similar to Yom Kippur. This reflects the Jewish concept that proper confession can achieve atonement even at life's end.

[v] The term "חִן" (chin) refers to grace or favor, while "אַנְחִין" (anachin) refers to sighing or moaning. The pairing creates both a rhyme and describes the supplicant's emotional state while praying.

אֵל וְאַל תַּפֶּן לְעַצְבִּי: דְּרוֹשׁ בַּעֲדִי [i] וְאַל תַּפֶּן לְמָרְדִּי: רְאֵה עֶלְבִּי [ii] וְרִיבָה אֶת יְרִיבִי: [iii]

me, O God, and do not regard my sorrow.[A] Seek [good] for me and do not regard my rebellion.[1] See my humiliation and contend with those who contend against me.[2]

1810 סדר יום שבת קדש [iv] Order for the holy Sabbath day[3] 2020R

יתחיל פסוקי אנא ה׳ הכתובים לעיל. ואח״כ יאמר מזמור משכיל לדוד בהיותו במערה וגו׳ תהלים סימן קמ״ב תמצא לעיל סדר ח׳ אחר כך יאמר זה:

Begin with the verses of “Ana Hashem” written above. And afterward recite Psalm 142, “Maskil of David, when he was in the cave, etc.,” which can be found above in the Eighth Order. Then say this:

(תורה) אִם יִהְיֶה נִדַּחֲךָ בִּקְצֵה [v] הַשָּׁמָיִם [vi] מִשָּׁם יְקַבֶּצְךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ וּמִשָּׁם יִקָּחֶךָ: וּמָל יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֶת

(Torah) Even if your outcasts are at the ends of the heavens, from there the LORD your God will gather you, and from there He will take you. And the LORD 2025R

interpreted as “supplication” or “plea” rather than “grace,” and “אַחְנִין” more specifically refers to groaning or moaning in distress.

[A] Or: “and do not turn to my grief” — The verb “תַּפֶּן” literally means “to turn to” or “to face,” suggesting God should turn away from rather than attend to the petitioner’s negative emotional state.

[1] The Hebrew term “מָרְדִּי” (my rebellion) carries stronger connotations than simple disobedience, suggesting willful defiance against divine authority. The prayer asks God to look past this serious transgression.

[2] This concluding request employs a common biblical theme where the petitioner asks God to take up their cause against enemies or adversaries. It echoes Psalm 35:1, “Contend, O LORD, with those who contend with me; fight against those who fight against me.”

[3] This heading introduces a special prayer sequence for the Sabbath within Ma’avar Yabok’s larger system of daily prayers. The Sabbath receives particular attention in Jewish mystical thought, as it is considered a time when divine mercy is more accessible and spiritual realms are more closely connected.

[i] The phrase “אַל תַּפֶּן” (do not regard/turn to) appears twice in this prayer, first asking God not to regard the supplicant’s sorrow, then asking God not to regard their rebellion. This creates a parallel structure emphasizing what the petitioner hopes God will and won’t attend to.

[ii] The term “עֶלְבִּי” (elbi) refers to humiliation or insult, while “יְרִיבִי” (yerivi) refers to one’s adversaries. The final phrase uses a wordplay with “וְרִיבָה” (verivah) meaning “contend with” and “יְרִיבִי” (yerivi) meaning “my contenders/adversaries.”

[iii] Cf. Psalm 35:1 — The final phrase of this prayer echoes this psalm’s opening, using the same rhetorical device of asking God to become an advocate against one’s enemies. | Cf. Lamentations 1:20 — This prayer echoes Lamentations’ pattern of acknowledging personal rebellion while still appealing to God for mercy and intervention against enemies.

[iv] This is a heading for a liturgical section focused on Sabbath prayers and observances within Ma’avar Yabok. In this context, ‘seder’ (order) refers to a structured sequence of prayers and rituals.

[v] This marker at the beginning of the passage indicates that these verses are from the Torah (Pentateuch), the first five books of the Hebrew Bible. This labeling system helps organize the biblical verses by their source, following a pattern seen throughout Ma’avar Yabok’s prayer sequences.

[vi] This phrase literally means “at the edge of the heavens” and evokes the image of being at the farthest possible distance from God, spiritually or physically. In the context of illness, it may metaphorically represent the feeling of spiritual distance that suffering can create.

לְבָבְךָ[i] וְאֶת לְבַב זַרְעֶךָ לְאַהֲבָה
1820 אֶת יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכָל לְבָבְךָ וּבְכָל
נַפְשְׁךָ לְמַעַן חַיֶּיךָ: וְהוֹתִירְךָ יְיָ
אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכֹל מַעֲשֵׂה יָדֶךָ בִּפְרִי
בִטְנְךָ וּבִפְרִי בְהֶמְתְּךָ וּבִפְרִי
אַדְמָתְךָ לְטוֹבָה כִּי יָשׂוּב יְיָ
1825 לָשׂוּשׂ עָלֶיךָ לְטוֹב כַּאֲשֶׁר שָׂשׂ
עַל אֲבֹתֶיךָ: חִזְקוּ וְאִמְצוּ אַל
תִּירְאוּ וְאַל תַּעַרְצוּ מִפְּנֵיהֶם
כִּי יְיָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ הוּא הַהֹלֵךְ עִמָּךְ
לֹא יַרְפְּךָ וְלֹא יַעַזְבֶךָּ: וַיְיָ הוּא
1830 הַהֹלֵךְ לְפָנֶיךָ הוּא יִהְיֶה עִמָּךְ לֹא
יַרְפְּךָ וְלֹא יַעַזְבֶךָּ לֹא תִירָא וְלֹא
תֵחָת: הַאֲזִינוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וַאֲדַבֵּרָה
וְתִשְׁמַע הָאָרֶץ אִמְרֵי פִי: יַעֲרֹף
כַּמָּטָר לִקְחִי[ii] תִּזַּל כַּטַּל אִמְרָתִי
1835 כִּשְׂעִירִם עֲלֵי דֶשֶׁא וְכִרְבִיבִים
עֲלֵי עֵשֶׂב: כִּי שֵׁם יְיָ אֶקְרָא הָבוּ
גֹדֶל לֵאלֹהֵינוּ:[iii]

your God will circumcise your heart[1] and the heart of your offspring, to love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul, for the sake of your life. And the LORD your God will prosper you abundantly in all the work of your hands, in the fruit of your womb, in the fruit of your cattle, and in the fruit of your soil, for good; for the LORD will again rejoice over you for good, as He rejoiced over your fathers. Be strong and courageous,[2] do not fear or be dismayed because of them, for the LORD your God is the One who goes with you; He will not fail you or forsake you. And the LORD is the One who goes before you; He will be with you, He will not fail you or forsake you; do not fear or be dismayed. Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak; and let the earth hear the words of my mouth. May my teaching drop like rain,[3] my speech distill like dew, like gentle rain upon the tender grass, and like showers upon the herb. For I proclaim the name of the LORD; ascribe greatness to our God.[4]

2030R 2035R 2040R 2045R

(נביאים) יָשׂוּב יְרַחֵמְנוּ יִכְבֹּשׁ

(Prophets) He will return and have compassion on

[1]Heart circumcision serves as a powerful metaphor for the spiritual purification that can come through suffering. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that illness itself can function as a divine instrument to remove spiritual barriers and open one's heart to deeper love of God.

[2]This phrase ('chizku ve'imtzu') comes from words of encouragement originally given to Joshua and Israel before battle. In Ma'avar Yabok, these military encouragements are repurposed as spiritual comfort for the sick and dying, transforming the battlefield into the struggle against illness and death.

[3]The Hebrew verbs for 'drop' (ya'arof) and 'distill' (tizal) create a beautiful image of divine teaching gently descending like life-giving precipitation. In the context of prayers for healing, these verses suggest that divine words themselves have restorative power, refreshing the parched soul of the suffering person.

[4]This concluding phrase shifts from Moses speaking to an exhortation for the listeners to respond, creating a dialogical element in the prayer. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this invites the sick person and those attending them to acknowledge divine sovereignty even in the midst of suffering.

[i]Heart circumcision is a recurring metaphor in biblical literature for spiritual transformation. Unlike physical circumcision which removes flesh, heart circumcision involves removing spiritual impediments to loving God fully.

[ii]The verb יַעֲרֹף (ya'arof) has the unusual double meaning of both "to drop (like rain)" and "to break the neck." This wordplay connects the life-giving nature of rain with the sacrificial breaking of an animal's neck, suggesting that divine teaching involves both nurturing and breaking.

[iii]Cf. Deuteronomy 30:3-6 — These verses from Deuteronomy about divine gathering and heart circumcision are used here to provide comfort to someone who is ill, creating a spiritual connection between physical healing and the promised divine ingathering of Israel. The imagery of God circumcising the heart represents spiritual purification that the ill person may experience through their suffering. | Cf. Deuteronomy 31:6-8 — These verses of encouragement were originally spoken by Moses to Israel and Joshua before entering the Promised Land. In Ma'avar Yabok, they're repurposed to comfort the sick, assuring them that God is present in their suffering and will not abandon them in their time of need. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:1-3 — These opening verses from Moses's final song are included to invoke divine attention to the prayers being offered. The comparison of teaching to rain and dew suggests that divine words bring life and refreshment to the suffering person, just as rain revives withered vegetation.

עֲוֹנֹתֵינוּ וְתַשְׁלִיךְ בִּמְצֻלוֹת יָם כָּל
1840 חַטֹּאותָם: תִּתֵּן אֱמֶת לְיַעֲקֹב חֶסֶד
לְאַבְרָהָם אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁבַּעְתָּ לַאֲבֹתֵינוּ
מִימֵי קֶדֶם: טוֹב יְיָ לְמָעוֹז בְּיוֹם
צָרָה וְיֹדֵעַ חֹסֵי בוֹ: לָמָּה תַרְאֵנִי
אָוֶן וְעָמָל תַּבִּיט וְשֹׁד וְחָמָס לְנֶגְדִּי
1845 וַיְהִי רִיב וּמָדוֹן יִשָּׂא: טְהוֹר
עֵינַיִם מֵרְאוֹת רָע וְהַבִּיט אֶל עָמָל
לֹא תוּכָל לָמָּה תַבִּיט בּוֹגְדִים
תַּחֲרִישׁ בְּבַלַּע רָשָׁע צַדִּיק מִמֶּנּוּ:
יְיָ שָׁמַעְתִּי שִׁמְעֲךָ יָרֵאתִי[i] יְיָ פָּעָלְךָ
1850 בְּקֶרֶב שָׁנִים חַיֵּהוּ בְּקֶרֶב שָׁנִים
תּוֹדִיעַ בְּרֹגֶז רַחֵם תִּזְכּוֹר:[ii] וַאֲנִי
בַּיהוָה אֶעְלוֹזָה אָגִילָה בֵּאלֹהֵי
יִשְׁעִי: יְיָ אֲדֹנָי חֵילִי וַיָּשֶׂם רַגְלַי
כָּאַיָּלוֹת[iii] וְעַל בָּמוֹתַי יַדְרִכֵנִי
1855 [v iv] לַמְנַצֵּחַ בִּנְגִינוֹתָי:

us;[1] He will subdue our iniquities and cast all their
sins into the depths of the sea.[2] You will give truth to 2050R
Jacob and loving-kindness to Abraham, as You have
sworn to our fathers from days of old. The LORD
is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble, and He
knows those who take refuge in Him. Why do You
show me iniquity, and cause me to behold trouble? 2055R
For destruction and violence are before me; strife and
contention arise.[A] You who are of purer eyes than to
behold evil, and cannot look on wickedness, why do
You look on those who deal treacherously,[3] and hold
Your tongue when the wicked devours one more right- 2060R
eous than he? O LORD, I have heard Your speech
and was afraid; O LORD, revive Your work in the
midst of the years! In the midst of the years make it
known; in wrath remember mercy.[4] Yet I will rejoice
in the LORD, I will joy in the God of my salvation. 2065R
The LORD God is my strength; He will make my feet
like deer's feet,[5] and He will make me walk on my

[A] Or: "and there is strife, and contention flourishes" — This alternate translation better captures the Hebrew 'yissa' which suggests something being lifted up or flourishing, rather than simply arising. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this emphasizes how conflict and discord actively grow in environments of injustice.

[1] The Hebrew verb 'yashuv' (will return) carries connotations of repentance and restoration, suggesting not just God's return to His people but a complete reversal of their condition.
[2] This powerful metaphor for complete forgiveness suggests sins being placed where they can never be retrieved—a comforting image for the sick person concerned about spiritual standing.
[3] Habakkuk's bold questioning of divine justice reflects the Jewish tradition of wrestling with God. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this gives voice to the sick person's legitimate spiritual struggles without suggesting lack of faith.
[4] This central plea reflects Ma'avar Yabok's theological framework that illness may serve as divine correction (wrath) while still being administered with compassion (mercy).
[5] The image shifts from physical disability to supernatural ability, suggesting that divine strength manifests most powerfully in human weakness—a theme especially relevant for the ill.

[i] The word expresses holy fear or awe rather than simple fright—it represents the appropriate response to divine revelation, combining reverence with trembling.
[ii] This phrase powerfully expresses the central theological concept in Ma'avar Yabok that divine judgment is always tempered with mercy. Even in wrath (rogez), God remembers (tizkor) compassion (rachem).
[iii] The image of deer's feet refers to sure-footedness on difficult terrain, suggesting divine assistance in navigating the challenges of illness and suffering.
[iv] This musical direction, literally "To the conductor with my stringed instruments," appears in Habakkuk 3:19 as the conclusion to the prophet's prayer. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, it suggests that even suffering can ultimately be transformed into a song of praise.
[v] Cf. Micah 7:19-20 — These verses serve as a foundation for hope in divine mercy during times of suffering, connecting the sick person's situation to God's historical covenant faithfulness | Cf. Nahum 1:7 — This verse provides comfort to the sick by presenting God as a reliable refuge in times of distress | Cf. Habakkuk 1:3, 1:13 — These verses give voice to the sick person's spiritual struggles, allowing them to express confusion about suffering while maintaining faith | Cf. Habakkuk 3:2, 3:18-19 — These verses model the ideal spiritual response to suffering: honest prayer followed by determined joy in God despite circumstances

high hills.[A] To the Chief Musician with my stringed instruments.

(תהלים) אִם אֵלֵךְ בְּקֶרֶב צָרָה
תְּחַיֵּנִי[i] עַל אַף אֹיְבַי תִּשְׁלַח יָדֶךָ
וְתוֹשִׁיעֵנִי יְמִינֶךָ: יְהוָה יִגְמֹר בַּעֲדִי
יְהוָה חַסְדְּךָ לְעוֹלָם מַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ
אַל תֶּרֶף: כִּי אֵין מִלָּה בִּלְשׁוֹנִי
הֵן יְיָ יָדַעְתָּ כֻּלָּהּ: חָלְצֵנִי יְיָ
מֵאָדָם רָע מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים תִּנְצְרֵנִי:
אֲשֶׁר חָשְׁבוּ רָעוֹת בְּלֵב כָּל יוֹם
יָגוּרוּ מִלְחָמוֹת: שָׁנְנוּ לְשׁוֹנָם כְּמוֹ
נָחָשׁ חֲמַת עַכְשׁוּב תַּחַת שִׂפְתֵימוֹ
סֶלָה:[ii] שָׁמְרֵנִי יְיָ מִידֵי רָשָׁע
מֵאִישׁ חֲמָסִים תִּנְצְרֵנִי אֲשֶׁר חָשְׁבוּ
לִדְחוֹת פְּעָמָי: אָמַרְתִּי לַיְיָ אֵלִי
אָתָּה הַאֲזִינָה יְיָ קוֹל תַּחֲנוּנָי:
אֲל תִּתֵּן יְיָ מַאֲוַיֵּי רָשָׁע זְמָמוֹ אַל
תָּפֵק יָרוּמוּ סֶלָה: אִישׁ לָשׁוֹן בַּל
יִכּוֹן בָּאָרֶץ אִישׁ חָמָס רָע יְצוּדֶנּוּ
לְמַדְחֵפוֹת: יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יַעֲשֶׂה יְיָ
דִּין עָנִי מִשְׁפַּט אֶבְיוֹנִים: תְּכוֹן
תְּפִלָּתִי קְטֹרֶת לְפָנֶיךָ מַשְׂאַת כַּפַּי
מִנְחַת עָרֶב:[iii] כִּי אֵלֶיךָ יְיָ אֲדֹנָי
עֵינָי בְּכָה חָסִיתִי אַל תְּעַר נַפְשִׁי:

(Psalms) Though I walk in the midst of trouble, You preserve my life;[1] You stretch out Your hand against the wrath of my enemies, and Your right hand saves me. The LORD will fulfill His purpose for me; Your steadfast love, O LORD, endures forever; do not abandon the works of Your hands. For there is not a word on my tongue, but behold, O LORD, You know it altogether. Deliver me, O LORD, from evil men; preserve me from violent men, who plan evil in their hearts; all day long they stir up wars. They sharpen their tongues like a serpent;[B] the venom of asps is under their lips.[2] Selah. Keep me, O LORD, from the hands of the wicked; preserve me from violent men who have planned to trip up my steps. I said to the LORD, "You are my God"; hear the voice of my supplications, O LORD. O LORD, do not grant the desires of the wicked; do not further their evil plot, lest they be exalted. Selah. As for the head of those who surround me, let the evil of their lips cover them. A man of tongue shall not be established in the earth;[C] a man of violence and evil shall be hunted with thrust upon thrust.[D] I know that the LORD

2070R 2075R 2080R 2085R 2090R

[A] Or: "and He makes me tread upon my heights" — This alternate translation better preserves the active sense of the Hebrew verb 'yadrikheni' (He makes me tread/walk) and maintains the metaphor of confident movement through challenging terrain, which is significant in the context of spiritual struggle during illness.

[B] Or: "They have sharpened their tongues like a serpent" — This alternate uses past tense rather than present, which might better reflect the perfective aspect of the Hebrew verb. Either translation is valid depending on whether one wishes to emphasize the completed action or ongoing state.

[C] Or: "The slanderer will not endure in the land" — This alternate offers a more dynamic translation that clarifies the meaning of 'man of tongue' (אִישׁ לָשׁוֹן) as a slanderer or malicious speaker, and might be more accessible to modern readers while maintaining the essential meaning.

[D] Or: "evil shall hunt him with overturning blows" — The Hebrew term 'מַדְחֵפוֹת' is difficult to translate precisely. This alternate interprets it as describing the nature of the hunting rather than as an adverbial phrase, which might better capture the intensity of the divine judgment described.

[1] This verse establishes the central theme of divine preservation even in the midst of suffering, which resonates throughout Ma'avar Yabok as a comfort for the sick and dying.

[2] While the original text uses vivid imagery of serpents and venom to describe human enemies, in the context of Ma'avar Yabok these metaphors take on additional meaning as spiritual forces that threaten the ill person—including the Angel of Death and negative spiritual accusers.

[i] This opening verse from Psalm 138:7 sets the tone for the entire compilation, expressing confidence that God preserves life even in the midst of trouble—a central theme for those who are ill.

[ii] The imagery of serpents and venom appears frequently in psalms as metaphors for dangerous enemies. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these enemies can be understood both as human adversaries and as spiritual forces threatening the ill person.

[iii] This verse from Psalm 141:2 is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as it connects to the work's fourth section titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer), which presents prayer as a spiritual substitute for the Temple incense offerings.

שָׁמְרֵנִי מִידֵי פַּח יָקְשׁוּ לִי וּמֹקְשׁוֹת
פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן: יִפְּלוּ בְמַכְמֹרָיו רְשָׁעִים
1880 יַחַד אָנֹכִי עַד אֶעֱבוֹר: קוֹלִי אֶל יְיָ
אֶזְעָק קוֹלִי אֶל יְיָ אֶתְחַנָּן: אֶשְׁפֹּךְ
לְפָנָיו שִׂיחִי צָרָתִי לְפָנָיו אַגִּיד:
בְּהִתְעַטֵּף [i]עָלַי רוּחִי וְאַתָּה יָדַעְתָּ
נְתִיבָתִי בְּאֹרַח זוּ אֲהַלֵּךְ טָמְנוּ
1885 פַּח לִי: הַבֵּיט יָמִין וּרְאֵה וְאֵין לִי
מַכִּיר אָבַד מָנוֹס מִמֶּנִּי אֵין דּוֹרֵשׁ
לְנַפְשִׁי:[ii] זָעַקְתִּי אֵלֶיךָ יְיָ אָמַרְתִּי
אַתָּה מַחְסִי חֶלְקִי בְּאֶרֶץ הַחַיִּים:
הַקְשִׁיבָה אֶל רִנָּתִי כִּי דַלּוֹתִי מְאֹד
1890 הַצִּילֵנִי מֵרֹדְפַי כִּי אָמְצוּ מִמֶּנִּי:
הוֹצִיאָה מִמַּסְגֵּר נַפְשִׁי לְהוֹדוֹת אֶת
שְׁמֶךָ בִּי יַכְתִּירוּ צַדִּיקִים כִּי תִגְמֹל
עָלָי: מִזְמוֹר לְדָוִד יְיָ שְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי
הַאֲזִינָה אֶל תַּחֲנוּנַי בֶּאֱמֶנְתְּךָ עֲנֵנִי
1895 בְּצִדְקָתֶךָ: וְאַל תָּבוֹא בְמִשְׁפָּט
אֶת עַבְדֶּךָ כִּי לֹא יִצְדַּק לְפָנֶיךָ
כָּל חָי: כִּי רָדַף אוֹיֵב נַפְשִׁי דִּכָּא
לָאָרֶץ חַיָּתִי הוֹשִׁיבַנִי בְמַחֲשַׁכִּים
כְּמֵתֵי עוֹלָם: וַתִּתְעַטֵּף עָלַי רוּחִי
1900 בְּתוֹכִי יִשְׁתּוֹמֵם לִבִּי: זָכַרְתִּי יָמִים
מִקֶּדֶם הָגִיתִי בְכָל פָּעֳלֶךָ בְּמַעֲשֵׂה
יָדֶיךָ אֲשׂוֹחֵחַ: פָּרַשְׂתִּי יָדַי אֵלֶיךָ
נַפְשִׁי כְּאֶרֶץ עֲיֵפָה לְךָ סֶלָה: מַהֵר
עֲנֵנִי יְיָ כָּלְתָה רוּחִי אַל תַּסְתֵּר
1905 פָּנֶיךָ מִמֶּנִּי וְנִמְשַׁלְתִּי עִם יֹרְדֵי
בוֹר: הַשְׁמִיעֵנִי בַבֹּקֶר חַסְדֶּךָ כִּי
בְךָ בָטָחְתִּי הוֹדִיעֵנִי דֶּרֶךְ זוּ אֵלֶךְ
כִּי אֵלֶיךָ נָשָׂאתִי נַפְשִׁי: הַצִּילֵנִי
מֵאוֹיְבַי יְהוָה אֵלֶיךָ כִּסִּתִי: לַמְּדֵנִי
1910 לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹנֶךָ כִּי אַתָּה אֱלוֹהַּ

will maintain the cause of the afflicted, and justice for the poor. Surely the righteous shall give thanks to Your name; the upright shall dwell in Your presence. Let my prayer be set before You as incense,[1] the 2095R lifting of my hands as the evening sacrifice. For my eyes are toward You, O LORD, my Lord; in You I take refuge; do not leave my soul destitute. Keep me from the trap they have set for me, and from the snares of evildoers. Let the wicked fall into their 2100R own nets, while I pass by safely. I cry out to the LORD with my voice; with my voice to the LORD I make my supplication. I pour out my complaint before Him; I declare my trouble before Him. When my spirit grows faint within me,[2] You know my path. 2105R In the way where I walk they have hidden a trap for me. Look to the right and see; for there is no one who acknowledges me; refuge has failed me; no one cares for my soul. I cry to You, O LORD; I say, "You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the 2110R living." Attend to my cry, for I am brought very low; deliver me from my persecutors, for they are stronger than I. Bring my soul out of prison,[A] that I may praise Your name; the righteous will surround me, for You will deal bountifully with me. A Psalm 2115R of David. O LORD, hear my prayer, give ear to my supplications; in Your faithfulness answer me, and in Your righteousness. Do not enter into judgment with Your servant, for in Your sight no one living is righteous. For the enemy has persecuted my soul; 2120R he has crushed my life to the ground; he has made me dwell in darkness, like those long dead. Therefore my spirit is overwhelmed within me; my heart within me is distressed. I remember the days of old;

[A] Or: "Free my soul from confinement" — This alternate uses more contemporary language that might better convey the metaphorical nature of the 'prison' (מַסְגֵּר) as any form of constraint or limitation, including illness, which would be relevant in Ma'avar Yabok's context.

[1] This metaphor comparing prayer to incense is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, whose fourth section is titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer). The text presents prayer as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings, creating the same cosmic effects as the physical incense once did.

[2] The Hebrew term 'בְּהִתְעַטֵּף' describes a wrapping or enveloping of the spirit, conveying profound spiritual distress. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connects to the experience of the soul as it struggles during illness and approaches its transition at death.

[i] This phrase literally describes a spirit/soul that is wrapped around or enveloped, conveying a sense of being spiritually overwhelmed. In Ma'avar Yabok, this connects to the concept of the soul's struggle during illness and its eventual transition at death.

[ii] This expression of abandonment—'no one cares for my soul'—is particularly poignant in the context of Ma'avar Yabok, which emphasizes the importance of community presence with the sick and dying.

רוּחֶךָ טוֹבָה תַּנְחֵנִי בְּאֶרֶץ מִישׁוֹר:
לְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ יְיָ תְּחַיֵּנִי בְּצִדְקָתְךָ
תּוֹצִיא מִצָּרָה נַפְשִׁי:[i][ii]

I meditate on all Your works; I ponder on the work of Your hands. I spread out my hands to You; my soul longs for You like a thirsty land. Selah. Answer me speedily, O LORD; my spirit fails. Do not hide Your face from me, lest I be like those who go down into the pit.[1] Cause me to hear Your lovingkindness in the morning, for in You do I trust; cause me to know the way in which I should walk, for I lift up my soul to You. Deliver me, O LORD, from my enemies; in You I take shelter. Teach me to do Your will, for You are my God; Your Spirit is good. Lead me in the land of uprightness. Revive me, O LORD, for Your name's sake; for Your righteousness' sake bring my soul out of trouble."[2]

(כתובים) הִנְנוּ לְפָנֶיךָ
בְּאַשְׁמָתֵינוּ[iii] כִּי אֵין לַעֲמוֹד
לְפָנֶיךָ עַל זֹאת: קוּם כִּי עָלֶיךָ
הַדָּבָר וַאֲנַחְנוּ עִמָּךְ חֲזַק וַעֲשֵׂה:
אָנָּא אֲדֹנָי תְּהִי נָא אָזְנְךָ קַשֻּׁבָה
אֶל תְּפִלַּת עַבְדְּךָ וְאֶל תְּפִלַּת
עֲבָדֶיךָ הַחֲפֵצִים לְיִרְאָה אֶת שְׁמֶךָ
וְהַצְלִיחָה נָא לְעַבְדְּךָ הַיּוֹם וּתְנֵהוּ

(Writings) Here we stand before You in our guilt,[3] for we cannot stand before You because of this. Arise, for the matter is upon you, and we are with you; be strong and act. Please, O Lord, let Your ear be attentive to the prayer of Your servant and to the prayer of Your servants who desire to fear Your name. Grant success to Your servant today and give him compassion before this man.[4] Remember me,

[1] This reference to 'those who go down into the pit' (יֹרְדֵי בוֹר) appears frequently in the psalms as a euphemism for death or the grave. In Ma'avar Yabok, these expressions take on special significance as the text prepares the soul for its journey beyond physical life.

[2] The psalm compilation concludes with this appeal to divine righteousness rather than human merit, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's consistent theological position that divine mercy—not human deservingness—is the basis for salvation from both physical and spiritual distress.

[3] This opening adapts language from penitential prayers found in Ezra and Daniel, establishing a confession of sin as the foundation for approaching God in time of need.

[4] This phrase from Nehemiah 1:11 originally referred to King Artaxerxes, but is adapted here to apply to whoever has authority over the sufferer's situation—perhaps a physician, caretaker, or other authority figure whose compassion is being sought.

[i] The compilation concludes with this plea for divine intervention based not on the supplicant's merit but on God's name and righteousness. This reflects the theological stance throughout Ma'avar Yabok that emphasizes divine mercy rather than human deservingness.

[ii] Cf. Psalms 138:7-8 — The passage begins with verses from Psalm 138, establishing a tone of divine protection and mercy that sets the foundation for this prayer collection used for the sick and dying. | Cf. Psalm 139:4 — This reference emphasizes God's omniscience, suggesting that even when the sick person cannot properly articulate prayers, God already knows their thoughts and needs. | Cf. Psalm 140:1-13 — In Ma'avar Yabok, these verses take on a metaphorical meaning where the 'enemies' represent illness, suffering, and spiritual accusers that threaten the sick person. | Cf. Psalm 141:2 — This reference connects to the fourth section of Ma'avar Yabok titled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer), reinforcing the concept that prayer serves as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings. | Cf. Psalm 142:1-7 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this psalm reflects the experience of the sick or dying person who feels isolated and overwhelmed, seeking divine refuge when human help fails. | Cf. Psalm 143:1-12 — Psalm 143 appears in Ma'avar Yabok's structured liturgical sequences specifically in the context of prayers for the dying. Its themes of divine judgment, human frailty, and appeal for mercy make it especially appropriate for deathbed contexts.

[iii] The prayer opens with an acknowledgment of guilt before God, a common theme in Jewish penitential prayers that establishes the appropriate spiritual stance for seeking divine mercy.

לְרַחֲמִים לִפְנֵי הָאִישׁ הַזֶּה: וַתִּכְרֶה
לִּי אֱלֹהַי לְטוֹבָה כֹּל אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתִי
עַל הָעָם הַזֶּה: וּבְרַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים
1925 לֹא עָשִׂיתָם כָּלָה וְלֹא עֲזַבְתָּם כִּי
אֵל חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם אָתָּה: וְאַתָּה צַדִּיק
עַל כָּל הַבָּא עָלֵינוּ כִּי אֱמֶת עָשִׂיתָ
וַאֲנַחְנוּ הִרְשָׁעְנוּ: וְרוּחַ לָבְשָׁה אֶת
עֲמָשַׂי[i] רֹאשׁ הַשָּׁלִשִׁים לְךָ דָוִיד
1930 וְעִמְּךָ בֶן יִשַׁי שָׁלוֹם שָׁלוֹם לָךְ
וְשָׁלוֹם לְעֹזְרֶךָ כִּי עֶזְרְךָ אֱלֹהֶיךָ
וַיְקַבְּלֵם דָּוִיד וַיִּתְּנֵם בְּרָאשֵׁי
הַגְּדוּד: [ii] הוֹדוּ לַיהוָה קִרְאוּ
בִשְׁמוֹ הוֹדִיעוּ בָעַמִּים עֲלִילֹתָיו:
1935 אַל תִּגְּעוּ בִּמְשִׁיחָי וּבִנְבִיאַי אַל
תָּרֵעוּ: וְאִמְרוּ הוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ אֱלֹהֵי
יִשְׁעֵנוּ וְקַבְּצֵנוּ וְהַצִּילֵנוּ מִן הַגּוֹיִם
לְהֹדוֹת לְשֵׁם קָדְשֶׁךָ לְהִשְׁתַּבֵּחַ
בִּתְהִלָּתֶךָ: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל
1940 מִן הָעוֹלָם וְעַד הָעֹלָם[iii] וַיֹּאמְרוּ
כָּל הָעָם אָמֵן וְהַלֵּל לַיְיָ: וְיֵאָמֵן
וְיִגְדַּל שִׁמְךָ עַד עוֹלָם לֵאמֹר יְיָ
צְבָאוֹת אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֱלֹהִים
לְיִשְׂרָאֵל וּבֵית דָּוִיד עַבְדְּךָ נָכוֹן
1945 [iv] לְפָנֶיךָ:

my God, for good, all that I have done for this people. In Your abundant mercy, You did not make an end of them nor forsake them, for You are a gracious and merciful God. You are righteous concerning all 2150R
that has come upon us, for You have acted truthfully, and we have acted wickedly.[A] And the spirit clothed Amasai, chief of the captains:[B] "Yours, David, and with you, son of Jesse! Peace, peace to you, and peace to your helper, for your God helps you."[1] And 2155R
David received them and placed them among the leaders of the troop. Give thanks to the LORD, call upon His name, make known His deeds among the peoples.[2] Do not touch My anointed ones, and do not harm My prophets. And say, "Save us, O God 2160R
of our salvation, and gather us and deliver us from the nations, to give thanks to Your holy name, to glory in Your praise." Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, from everlasting to everlasting. And all the people said, "Amen" and praised the LORD. 2165R
And may Your name be established and magnified forever, saying, "The LORD of hosts, God of Israel, is God to Israel, and the house of David Your servant is established before You."[3]

[A] Or: "You are just in all that has befallen us, for You have dealt faithfully, while we have acted wickedly" — This alternate translation uses "just" instead of "righteous" and "dealt faithfully" instead of "acted truthfully" to provide a more fluid English rendering while maintaining the theological contrast between God's justice and human sinfulness.

[B] Or: "And a spirit enveloped Amasai, chief of the officers" — The Hebrew "לָבְשָׁה" (lavshah) literally means "clothed" or "wore," but in this context of spiritual possession or inspiration, "enveloped" better conveys the sense of being overtaken by divine inspiration. Also, "השלישים" can be translated as "officers" rather than "captains" for a more contemporary military understanding.

[1] The inclusion of this biblical narrative about Amasai's divinely inspired pledge to David serves as a powerful metaphor: just as God confirmed David's right to leadership and promised him help, so too the prayer seeks divine confirmation and help for the petitioner in their time of need.

[2] The prayer shifts from personal petition to communal praise, drawing from David's psalm in 1 Chronicles 16. This movement from individual need to communal worship places the petitioner's suffering within the broader context of God's salvation history.

[3] The prayer concludes by affirming God's eternal covenant with Israel and David, providing ultimate assurance that despite present suffering, God's promises remain secure and will be fulfilled.

[i] This reference to 1 Chronicles 12:18 describes a moment when Amasai was divinely inspired to pledge loyalty to David. The Hebrew expression "the spirit clothed" (רוח לבשה) conveys the idea of being completely overtaken or enveloped by divine inspiration.

[ii] This completes the narrative from 1 Chronicles 12:18, showing that David accepted those who came to him, just as the prayer asks God to accept the petitioner.

[iii] This doxology (formal praise to God) comes from 1 Chronicles 16:36 and forms part of the standard conclusion to the first book of Psalms (Psalm 41:14), marking a natural ending point for the prayer.

[iv] Cf. Ezra 9:15 — The author incorporates this confession of communal sin from Ezra to express complete submission to divine judgment, acknowledging God's justice in whatever suffering may befall the person. | Cf. 1 Chronicles 12:18 — By including this biblical narrative of divine

חֲבוֹשׁ סִבְרִי מְצוּדָתִי וְנֹרִי.[i] וְסִבְרִי בָּךְ לְחַתֵּל בִּי כְּאֵבִי.[ii] יְחִידָתִי[iii] לְבַד בִּשְׁמָךְ תְּיַחֵל וְחֵן לָךְ אֵל יְקַוֶּה אֶת לִבָּבִי:[iv]

Bind up my hope,[A] my fortress, and my light.[1] And my hope is in You to heal my pain. My soul[B] alone will wait upon Your name,[2] and behold, my heart will hope in You, O God.[3] 2170R

1950 מנחה ליום שבת

Afternoon Prayer for the Sabbath Day

אמר פסוקי אנא ה׳[v] ואחר כך יאמר מזמור ה׳ שמע תפלתי וגו׳ תהלים סימן קמ״ג[vi] תמצא לעיל

Say the verses of "Ana Hashem"[4] and then recite Psalm 143, "O LORD, hear my prayer, etc." which can be found above in Seder 8,[5] and afterwards say:[6] 2175R

[A] Or: "Bandage my hope" — This translation emphasizes the medical metaphor more explicitly, as חֲבוֹשׁ specifically refers to binding wounds. This would be preferable if wanting to highlight the connection between physical and spiritual healing that appears throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[B] Or: "My solitary one" — This more literal translation of יְחִידָתִי preserves the sense of isolation or uniqueness implied in the Hebrew, which might be preferable for emphasizing the soul's vulnerability and singular dependence on God.

[1] The Hebrew חֲבוֹשׁ carries the medical sense of binding up wounds, suggesting that the speaker's spiritual resources (hope, fortress, light) need divine healing or strengthening.

[2] The Hebrew יְחִידָתִי (literally 'my only one') is a traditional poetic term for the soul, especially when in danger, creating a sense of the soul's singular focus on God during distress.

[3] The concluding phrase presents a chiastic structure with the opening line—beginning with hope (סִבְרִי) and ending with hope (יְקַוֶּה), creating a full circle of dependence on divine assistance.

[4] These instructions are clearly part of a step-by-step guide for performing deathbed rituals. The text assumes the reader knows which "Ana Hashem" verses to recite, as these would be standard in the liturgical context of Ma'avar Yabok.

[5] This reference to "Seder 8" demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok functions as a practical manual with internal cross-references. Rather than repeating the full text of Psalm 143, it directs the reader to where it appears earlier in the book.

[6] This instruction indicates that what follows (not included in this excerpt) would be the next step in the ritual sequence. The colon suggests that the next text would provide the specific words to be recited after Psalm 143.

confirmation of David's leadership, the prayer seeks divine validation and assistance for the ill person, suggesting that just as God helped David in crisis, so too will God help the sufferer. | Cf. Nehemiah 1:6-11 — The prayer borrows Nehemiah's language to similarly request divine favor before approaching an earthly authority figure (possibly a physician or caretaker), asking God to make this person merciful toward the petitioner. | Cf. 1 Chronicles 16:8, 22, 35-36 — By incorporating this hymn of praise into a prayer for the sick, the text reminds the sufferer of God's covenant faithfulness and power to save, suggesting that the same God who protected Israel will protect the individual in their illness.

[i] Poetic opening using the imperative 'bind up' (חֲבוֹשׁ) followed by three nouns with first-person possessive suffixes: 'my hope,' 'my fortress,' and 'my light.' This creates a triad of spiritual resources the speaker seeks to have secured or strengthened.

[ii] The verb לְחַתֵּל carries the sense of binding wounds or swaddling an infant, creating a powerful image of God tenderly treating the speaker's pain.

[iii] יְחִידָתִי (literally 'my only one') is a traditional poetic reference to the soul, particularly in contexts of danger or distress. This creates a parallel to Psalm 22:21 and 35:17 where the same term appears.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 31:25 — This poetic prayer echoes the psalmist's expressions of hope in God during times of distress, particularly drawing on the language and sentiment of Psalm 31, where the psalmist declares trust in God despite suffering. | Cf. Psalm 62:6 — The phrase 'my soul alone will wait upon Your name' parallels Psalm 62's expression of the soul's exclusive reliance on God as the only true source of hope, especially in times of suffering.

[v] "Ana Hashem" (Please, O LORD) refers to the opening formula that begins each of the prayer sequences in Ma'avar Yabok, a set of verses that start with this phrase.

[vi] Psalm 143 is specifically prescribed for recitation at times of distress or when approaching death. Its themes of divine mercy despite human frailty and appeals for guidance make it particularly appropriate in this context.

סדר ח׳ ואח״כ יאמר: [i]

(תורה) הַצּוּר תָּמִים פָּעֳלוֹ כִּי כָל דְּרָכָיו מִשְׁפָּט אֵל אֱמוּנָה וְאֵין עָוֶל צַדִּיק וְיָשָׁר הוּא: כִּי חֵלֶק יְיָ עַמּוֹ יַעֲקֹב חֶבֶל נַחֲלָתוֹ: כְּנֶשֶׁר יָעִיר קִנּוֹ עַל גּוֹזָלָיו יְרַחֵף יִפְרֹשׂ כְּנָפָיו יִקָּחֵהוּ יִשָּׂאֵהוּ עַל אֶבְרָתוֹ: יְיָ בָּדָד יַנְחֶנּוּ וְאֵין עִמּוֹ אֵל נֵכָר: יַרְכִּבֵהוּ עַל בָּמֳתֵי אֶרֶץ וַיֹּאכַל תְּנוּבֹת שָׂדָי וַיֵּנִקֵהוּ דְבַשׁ מִסֶּלַע וְשֶׁמֶן מֵחַלְמִישׁ צוּר: כִּי יָדִין יְיָ עַמּוֹ וְעַל עֲבָדָיו יִתְנֶחָם כִּי יִרְאֶה כִּי אָזְלַת יָד וְאֶפֶס עָצוּר וְעָזוּב: בָּרֵךְ יְיָ חֵילוֹ וּפֹעַל יָדָיו תִּרְצֶה מְחַץ מָתְנַיִם קָמָיו וּמְשַׂנְאָיו מִן יְקוּמוּן: אַשְׁרֶיךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל מִי כָמוֹךָ עַם נוֹשַׁע בַּיהוָה מָגֵן עֶזְרֶךָ וַאֲשֶׁר חֶרֶב גַּאֲוָתֶךָ וְיִכָּחֲשׁוּ אֹיְבֶיךָ לָךְ [ii] וְאַתָּה עַל בָּמוֹתֵימוֹ תִּדְרֹךְ:

(Torah) The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are justice; a God of faithfulness without iniquity, righteous and upright is He. For the LORD's portion is His people; Jacob is the lot of His inheritance. Like an eagle that stirs up its nest,[1] hovers over its young, spreads its wings, takes them, bears them on its pinions—the LORD alone guided him, and there was no foreign god with him. He made him ride on the high places of the earth, and he ate the produce of the fields; He made him suck honey from the rock, and oil from the flinty stone. For the LORD will judge His people and have compassion on His servants when He sees that their power is gone,[2] and there is no one, bond or free. Bless, O LORD, his substance, and accept the work of his hands; smite the loins of those who rise up against him, and of those who hate him, that they rise no more.[A] Happy are you, O Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD, the shield of your help, and who is the sword of your excellency! Your enemies shall submit themselves to you,[B] and you shall tread upon their high places."[3]

(נביאים) הֵסִיר יְהוָה מִשְׁפָּטַיִךְ

(Prophets) The LORD has taken away your judg-

[A] Or: "that they cannot arise" — The Aramaic-influenced form 'yekumun' can be translated either as 'they rise no more' or 'they cannot arise,' with the latter perhaps capturing the finality of the defeat more explicitly.

[B] Or: "Your enemies shall cringe before you" — The Hebrew 'yikachashu' has connotations of both submission and cowering falsely or insincerely, so 'cringe before you' captures the sense that the enemies' submission is not wholehearted but forced.

[1] This powerful metaphor depicts God as a protective eagle teaching its young to fly—a particularly comforting image in Ma'avar Yabok's context of ministering to the sick or dying, suggesting divine support during life's transitions.

[2] The phrase 'אָזְלַת יָד' literally 'the hand has gone away' refers to weakness or helplessness, particularly relevant in the context of illness where physical strength diminishes.

[3] The prayer concludes with imagery of triumph and sovereignty, offering spiritual encouragement that transcends physical decline by focusing on Israel's ultimate victory through divine assistance.

[i] "Can be found above in Seder 8" refers to the eighth liturgical order or sequence within Ma'avar Yabok's structured prayer system. This cross-reference indicates that the complete text of Psalm 143 appears earlier in the book and need not be repeated in full here.

[ii] Cf. Deuteronomy 32:4-13 — This is a direct quotation from the Song of Moses in Deuteronomy, which praises God's perfect justice and His protective care for Israel. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses are used as part of a prayer for the sick or dying person, emphasizing God's perfect justice even in difficult circumstances and His special relationship with Israel. | Cf. Tziduk HaDin prayers — These verses are commonly incorporated into Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) prayers recited at funerals or during mourning. Their inclusion here connects to Ma'avar Yabok's extensive discussion of Tziduk HaDin in Chapter 21 of Discourse 2 and Chapter 26 of Discourse 5.

פְּנָה אוֹיְבֵךְ[i] מֶלֶךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה
בְּקִרְבֵּךְ לֹא תִירְאִי רָע עוֹד:
וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה אֶל הַשָּׂטָן יִגְעַר
יְהוָה בְּךָ הַשָּׂטָן[ii] וְיִגְעַר יְהוָה בָּךְ
הַבּוֹחֵר בִּירוּשָׁלַם הֲלוֹא זֶה אוּד
מֻצָּל מֵאֵשׁ:[iii] מִי אַתָּה הַר הַגָּדוֹל
לִפְנֵי זְרֻבָּבֶל לְמִישֹׁר וְהוֹצִיא
אֶת הָאֶבֶן הָרֹאשָׁה תְּשֻׁאוֹת חֵן
חֵן לָהּ:[iv] שׁוּבוּ לְבִצָּרוֹן אֲסִירֵי
הַתִּקְוָה[v] גַּם הַיּוֹם מַגִּיד מִשְׁנֶה
אָשִׁיב לָךְ:[vi] וְגִבַּרְתִּים בַּיהוָה
וּבִשְׁמוֹ יִתְהַלָּכוּ נְאֻם יְיָ: וְעָרְבָה
לַיהוָה מִנְחַת יְהוּדָה וִירוּשָׁלָם
כִּימֵי עוֹלָם וּכְשָׁנִים קַדְמֹנִיּוֹת:
וְזָרְחָה לָכֶם יִרְאֵי שְׁמִי שֶׁמֶשׁ

ments,[1] He has cleared away your enemy. The King of Israel, the LORD, is in your midst; you shall fear evil no more.[A] And the LORD said to Satan, "The LORD rebuke you, Satan! The LORD who has chosen Jerusalem rebuke you! Is this not 2205R a brand plucked from the fire?"[B2] "Who are you, O great mountain? Before Zerubbabel you shall become a plain![3] And he shall bring forth the capstone with shouts of 'Grace, grace to it!'" Return to the stronghold, you prisoners of hope.[4] Even to- 2210R day I declare that I will restore double to you.[5] "I will strengthen them in the LORD, and they shall walk up and down in His name," says the LORD. "Then the offering of Judah and Jerusalem will be pleasant to the LORD, as in the days of old, as in 2215R

[A] Or: "you shall no longer be afraid of harm" — This alternate translation uses more contemporary phrasing while maintaining the meaning. It might be preferred in contexts where a more accessible modern rendering is desired.

[B] Or: "a burning stick snatched from the flames" — This alternate provides a more concrete visual image that might be clearer to modern readers unfamiliar with the term 'brand' in this context.

[1] The Hebrew uses the feminine singular form, addressing a collective entity (Jerusalem/Zion) as a woman. This verse begins a series of prophetic passages offering reassurance of divine protection and presence.

[2] This powerful metaphor describes someone or something rescued from near destruction. In the liturgical context of Ma'avar Yabok, this image would resonate with the concept of the soul being rescued from spiritual danger during illness or at death.

[3] Zerubbabel was the Persian-appointed governor of Judah who helped lead the return from exile and the rebuilding of the Temple. The verse uses him as a symbol of divinely appointed leadership that can overcome seemingly insurmountable obstacles.

[4] This paradoxical phrase 'prisoners of hope' captures the tension experienced by those who are suffering yet maintain faith. In the context of illness or approaching death, this offers the divine presence as a stronghold or fortress of protection.

[5] This promise of double restoration echoes the legal principle where stolen goods were repaid twofold. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this suggests that spiritual compensation will exceed temporal suffering.

[i] This opening verse from Zephaniah 3:15 addresses Jerusalem collectively using feminine pronouns. The 'judgments' (מִשְׁפָּטִיךְ) here refer to divine punishments that have been removed, suggesting a transition from judgment to mercy.

[ii] This verse from Zechariah 3:2 features God speaking about Himself in the third person, creating a powerful rhetorical effect. The Hebrew 'Satan' (הַשָּׂטָן) functions here as 'the accuser' or adversary, not necessarily the personified evil being of later tradition.

[iii] This metaphor of 'a brand plucked from the fire' describes someone narrowly rescued from destruction. In the original context, it referred to Joshua the high priest, representing post-exilic Israel's narrow escape from national destruction.

[iv] The repeated word 'grace' (חֵן חֵן) creates an intensifying effect, emphasizing the abundance of divine favor. The feminine pronoun 'to her' (לָהּ) refers to the capstone mentioned earlier in the verse.

[v] The metaphor 'prisoners of hope' (אֲסִירֵי הַתִּקְוָה) presents hope as something that both imprisons (creates longing) and liberates. In the original context, this addressed exiles who were invited to return to Jerusalem.

[vi] The promise to restore 'double' draws on the legal concept where stolen property was to be repaid twofold (Exodus 22:4,7). This suggests divine compensation that exceeds what was lost.

צְדָקָה וּמַרְפֵּא בִּכְנָפֶיהָ[i] וְיִצָּאתֶם
וּפִשְׁתֶּם כְּעֶגְלֵי מַרְבֵּק: וְעַסּוֹתֶם
רְשָׁעִים כִּי יִהְיוּ אֵפֶר תַּחַת כַּפּוֹת
רַגְלֵיכֶם[ii] בַּיּוֹם אֲשֶׁר אֲנִי עֹשֶׂה
זֹאת[iii] אָמַר יְיָ צְבָאוֹת:

former years.[1] But to you who fear My name the Sun of Righteousness shall arise with healing in His wings;[2] you shall go out and grow fat like stall-fed calves.[A] You shall trample the wicked, for they shall be ashes under the soles of your feet[3] on the day that I do this," says the LORD of hosts. 2220R

(תהלים) לְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ יְיָ תְּחַיֵּנִי
בְּצִדְקָתְךָ[iv] תּוֹצִיא מִצָּרָה נַפְשִׁי:

(Psalms) For Your name's sake, O LORD, preserve my life;[4] in Your righteousness, deliver my soul from

[A] Or: "you shall go forth and frisk about like calves released from the stall" — This alternate captures the dynamic movement implied in the Hebrew metaphor rather than focusing on 'fatness,' emphasizing joy and freedom rather than just prosperity.

[1] This refers to the time when the Temple stood and sacrifices were properly offered. In the post-Temple period when Ma'avar Yabok was written, this would be understood as suggesting that prayers for the sick and dying are as acceptable to God as the ancient Temple offerings.

[2] This poetic metaphor blends solar imagery (the rising sun bringing light and warmth) with bird imagery (protective, healing wings). In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this offers a powerful image of divine healing and protection for the soul.

[3] This final verse presents ultimate vindication where those who now suffer will eventually triumph over forces of wickedness. In the eschatological framework of Ma'avar Yabok, this offers reassurance that current suffering will give way to ultimate victory in the divine future.

[4] This opening establishes a fundamental theological framework: appealing to God's own character and reputation rather than personal merit as the basis for divine intervention.

[i] This poetic image of the 'sun of righteousness' with 'healing in its wings' combines solar imagery with bird imagery. The 'wings' (כְּנָפֶיהָ) can refer both to the rays of the sun and to the protective wings of a bird, creating a rich multivalent metaphor.

[ii] The image of the wicked as 'ashes under the soles of your feet' creates a stark contrast with the previous verse's image of joyful calves leaping. This juxtaposition emphasizes the complete reversal of fortunes between the righteous and wicked.

[iii] Cf. Zephaniah 3:15 — This verse from Zephaniah offers comfort by declaring that God has removed judgments and enemies, providing divine protection within the community. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this verse emphasizes divine presence during times of transition, particularly comforting for those facing illness or death. | Cf. Zechariah 3:2 — This verse invokes divine protection against Satan/accusers, presenting God as defender. The metaphor of 'a brand plucked from the fire' represents rescue from destruction. In Ma'avar Yabok, this serves as spiritual protection for the sick or dying, symbolically rebuking spiritual accusers that might impede the soul's peaceful transition. | Cf. Zechariah 4:7 — This verse presents obstacles (the mountain) being leveled before Zerubbabel, with the capstone placed amid shouts of divine favor. In Ma'avar Yabok, this functions as a prayer for removing spiritual obstacles facing the sick person, transforming challenges into manageable circumstances through divine grace. | Cf. Zechariah 9:12 — This verse calls the 'prisoners of hope' to return to safety with a promise of double restoration. In Ma'avar Yabok, this provides reassurance that although one is imprisoned by illness, there is a stronghold of divine protection and promise of compensation for suffering. | Cf. Zechariah 10:12 — This verse promises divine strengthening and walking in God's name. In Ma'avar Yabok, this offers reassurance that even in weakness, God provides spiritual strength. The phrase 'walking in His name' suggests continuing in divine paths despite physical limitations, offering spiritual mobility even when physical mobility might be compromised. | Cf. Malachi 3:4 — This verse promises that offerings will become pleasing to God as in ancient times. In Ma'avar Yabok, this suggests that prayers offered by or for the sick will be accepted like Temple sacrifices, creating a connection between deathbed prayers and ancient Temple worship. | Cf. Malachi 4:2-3 — These verses promise that those who fear God's name will experience the rising of the 'sun of righteousness' with healing, leading to restoration and triumph over evil. In Ma'avar Yabok, this offers hope of divine healing for the sick or spiritual healing in the afterlife, presenting illness and death as transitions that lead to ultimate triumph over spiritual enemies.

[iv] The prayer begins with a verse from Psalm 143:11, appealing to God's own name and righteousness rather than the petitioner's merit as the basis for divine intervention.

וּבְחַסְדְּךָ תַּצְמִית אוֹיְבָי וְתַאֲבֵדְתָּ
כָּל צֹרְרֵי נַפְשִׁי כִּי אֲנִי עַבְדֶּךָ׃
חַסְדִּי וּמְצוּדָתִי מִשְׂגַּבִּי וּמְפַלְטִי
לִי מָגִנִּי וּבוֹ חָסִיתִי [i]הָרוֹדֵד עַמִּי
2000 תַּחְתָּי׃ פְּצֵנִי וְהַצִּילֵנִי מִיַּד בְּנֵי
נֵכָר׃ [ii]אֲשֶׁר פִּיהֶם דִּבֶּר שָׁוְא
וִימִינָם יְמִין שֶׁקֶר׃ אַשְׁרֵי הָעָם
שֶׁכָּכָה לּוֹ אַשְׁרֵי הָעָם שֶׁיְיָ אֱלֹהָיו׃
חַנּוּן וְרַחוּם יְיָ אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם וּגְדַל
2005 חָסֶד׃ [iii]טוֹב יְיָ לַכֹּל וְרַחֲמָיו
עַל כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו׃ סוֹמֵךְ יְיָ לְכָל
הַנֹּפְלִים וְזוֹקֵף לְכָל הַכְּפוּפִים׃
עֵינֵי כֹל אֵלֶיךָ יְשַׂבֵּרוּ וְאַתָּה נוֹתֵן
לָהֶם אֶת אָכְלָם בְּעִתּוֹ׃ פּוֹתֵחַ
2010 אֶת יָדֶךָ וּמַשְׂבִּיעַ לְכָל חַי רָצוֹן׃
קָרוֹב יְיָ לְכָל קֹרְאָיו לְכֹל אֲשֶׁר
יִקְרָאֻהוּ בֶּאֱמֶת׃ רְצוֹן יְרֵאָיו
יַעֲשֶׂה וְאֶת שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם׃
שׁוֹמֵר יְיָ אֶת כָּל אֹהֲבָיו וְאֵת
2015 כָּל הָרְשָׁעִים יַשְׁמִיד׃ תְּהִלַּת יְיָ
יְדַבֶּר פִּי וִיבָרֵךְ כָּל בָּשָׂר שֵׁם
קָדְשׁוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד׃ אֲשַׁרֵי שֶׁאֵל
יַעֲקֹב בְּעֶזְרוֹ שִׂבְרוֹ עַל יְיָ אֱלֹהָיו׃
עֹשֶׂה מִשְׁפָּט לָעֲשׁוּקִים נֹתֵן לֶחֶם
2020 לָרְעֵבִים יְיָ מַתִּיר אֲסוּרִים׃ יְיָ
פֹּקֵחַ עִוְרִים יְיָ זוֹקֵף כְּפוּפִים

distress. In Your mercy, cut off my enemies and destroy all the oppressors of my soul, for I am Your servant. My lovingkindness and my fortress, my stronghold and my deliverer, my shield in whom I take refuge,[1] who subdues peoples under me.[A] Rescue me and deliver me from the hands of foreigners, whose mouths speak falsehood and whose right hands are raised in deceit.[B] Happy is the people who have it so, happy is the people whose God is the LORD. The LORD is gracious and compassionate,[2] slow to anger and great in lovingkindness. The LORD is good to all, and His mercies are over all His works. The LORD supports all who fall and raises up all who are bowed down.[3] The eyes of all look expectantly to You, and You give them their food in due time. You open Your hand and satisfy the desire of every living thing. The LORD is near to all who call upon Him, to all who call upon Him in truth. He will fulfill the desire of those who fear Him; He will also hear their cry and save them. The LORD preserves all who love Him, but all the wicked He will destroy. My mouth will speak the praise of the LORD, and all flesh will bless His holy name forever and ever. Happy is he whose help is the God of Jacob, whose hope is in the LORD his God. He executes justice for the oppressed; He gives food to the

[A] Or: "who subdues my people beneath me" — The Hebrew phrase can be interpreted in two ways. The translation I provided follows the interpretation as 'subjecting nations under me' (referring to David's military victories), but this alternate considers the possessive 'my people' rather than 'peoples' in general. The context suggests the first interpretation is more likely, but both are grammatically possible.

[B] Or: "and whose right hand is a right hand of falsehood" — My original translation adds 'raised' for clarity and readability in English, but this more literal rendering maintains the Hebrew parallelism between 'their mouth speaks falsehood' and 'their right hand is a right hand of falsehood,' referring to false oaths sworn with the right hand raised.

[1] The accumulation of protective imagery (lovingkindness, fortress, stronghold, deliverer, shield) creates a powerful sense of divine encirclement, particularly meaningful for someone feeling vulnerable due to illness.

[2] This begins a meditation on divine attributes of mercy drawn from Psalm 145, shifting the prayer from petition to contemplation of God's compassionate nature.

[3] This verse takes on special significance in the context of illness, offering reassurance that even in physical weakness, God provides support and restoration.

[i] This verse from Psalm 144:2 uses military protective imagery (fortress, stronghold, deliverer, shield) to describe God's relationship to the worshipper, creating a sense of divine protection around the vulnerable individual.

[ii] In the psalm's original context, 'foreigners' referred to enemy nations, but in Ma'avar Yabok's context, this can be understood metaphorically as referring to harmful forces (spiritual or physical) that threaten the sick person.

[iii] This begins the section from Psalm 145, which forms the core of this compilation. The text shifts from personal petition to meditation on God's merciful attributes, providing comfort through focus on divine compassion.

יְיָ אֹהֵב צַדִּיקִים: יְיָ שֹׁמֵר אֶת
גֵּרִים יָתוֹם וְאַלְמָנָה יְעוֹדֵד וְדֶרֶךְ
רְשָׁעִים יְעַוֵּת: הָרֹפֵא לִשְׁבוּרֵי לֵב
וּמְחַבֵּשׁ לְעַצְּבוֹתָם:[i] גָּדוֹל אֲדוֹנֵינוּ
וְרַב כֹּחַ לִתְבוּנָתוֹ אֵין מִסְפָּר:
מְעוֹדֵד עֲנָוִים יְיָ מַשְׁפִּיל רְשָׁעִים
עָדֵי אֶרֶץ: הַשָּׁם גְּבוּלֵךְ שָׁלוֹם
חֵלֶב חִטִּים יַשְׂבִּיעֵךְ: בַּחוּרִים
וְגַם בְּתוּלוֹת זְקֵנִים עִם נְעָרִים:
יְהַלְלוּ אֶת שֵׁם יְיָ כִּי נִשְׂגָּב שְׁמוֹ
לְבַדּוֹ הוֹדוֹ עַל אֶרֶץ וְשָׁמָיִם: וַיָּרֶם
קֶרֶן לְעַמּוֹ תְּהִלָּה לְכָל חֲסִידָיו
לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל עַם קְרֹבוֹ הַלְלוּיָהּ:
הַלְלוּיָהּ שִׁירוּ לַייָ שִׁיר חָדָשׁ
תְּהִלָּתוֹ בִּקְהַל חֲסִידִים: כִּי רוֹצֶה
יְיָ בְּעַמּוֹ יְפָאֵר עֲנָוִים בִּישׁוּעָה:
יַעְלְזוּ חֲסִידִים בְּכָבוֹד יְרַנְּנוּ עַל
מִשְׁכְּבוֹתָם: רוֹמְמוֹת אֵל בִּגְרוֹנָם
וְחֶרֶב פִּיפִיּוֹת בְּיָדָם:[ii] לַעֲשׂוֹת
נְקָמָה בַּגּוֹיִם תּוֹכֵחוֹת בַּלְאֻמִּים:
לֶאְסֹר מַלְכֵיהֶם בְּזִקִים וְנִכְבְּדֵיהֶם
בְּכַבְלֵי בַרְזֶל: לַעֲשׂוֹת בָּהֶם מִשְׁפָּט
כָּתוּב הָדָר הוּא לְכָל חֲסִידָיו
הַלְלוּיָהּ: כֹּל הַנְּשָׁמָה תְּהַלֵּל יָהּ
הַלְלוּיָהּ.[iii][iv]

hungry. The LORD sets prisoners free. The LORD 2250R
opens the eyes of the blind; the LORD raises those
who are bowed down; the LORD loves the righteous.
The LORD protects the strangers; He sustains the
fatherless and the widow, but He thwarts the way of
the wicked. He heals the brokenhearted and binds up 2255R
their wounds.[1] Great is our Lord and abundant in
strength; His understanding is infinite. The LORD
supports the humble; He brings the wicked down to
the ground. He makes your borders peaceful; He sat-
isfies you with the finest wheat. Let young men and 2260R
maidens, old men and children, praise the name of
the LORD, for His name alone is exalted; His glory
is above earth and heaven. He has raised up a horn
for His people, praise for all His godly ones, for the
children of Israel, a people near to Him. Hallelujah! 2265R
Hallelujah! Sing to the LORD a new song, His praise
in the assembly of the godly. For the LORD takes
pleasure in His people; He adorns the humble with
salvation. Let the godly exult in glory; let them
sing for joy on their beds. Let the high praises of 2270R
God be in their throats and a two-edged sword in
their hands,[2] to execute vengeance on the nations
and punishment on the peoples, to bind their kings
with chains and their nobles with fetters of iron, to
execute on them the judgment written. This is an 2275R

[1] This verse about divine healing from Psalm 147:3 would be particularly meaningful for those who are ill or approaching death, emphasizing God's role as healer of both physical and emotional suffering.

[2] This powerful imagery suggests that prayer itself becomes a spiritual weapon. In Ma'avar Yabok's context for the sick and dying, this implies that even in physical weakness, one can participate in cosmic spiritual warfare through prayer.

[i] This verse from Psalm 147:3 about God healing the brokenhearted has special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of illness and approaching death.

[ii] This striking imagery from Psalm 149:6 of having praises in the throat while holding a sword suggests that prayer itself becomes a powerful weapon. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this implies that even the ill or dying can spiritually triumph through prayer.

[iii] The prayer concludes with the final verse of the Book of Psalms, emphasizing that as long as one has breath (נְשָׁמָה/neshamah), one can praise God. This carries profound meaning in the context of attending to those who are ill or dying.

[iv] Cf. Psalm 143:11 — This opening verse is a direct quote from Psalm 143, which is a prayer of David seeking deliverance from enemies. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this serves as a foundational plea for divine intervention based on God's own character rather than the petitioner's merit. | Cf. Psalm 145 — Psalm 145 forms the core of this prayer sequence, highlighting divine attributes of mercy and sustenance. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, these verses emphasize God's compassionate nature and willingness to support the fallen and vulnerable, providing comfort to the sick or dying person. | Cf. Psalm 146 — The inclusion of Psalm 146 reinforces trust in divine rather than human assistance during illness. The specific attributes of God emphasized (helping the oppressed, hungry, prisoners, blind) would resonate with someone feeling physically constrained or diminished by illness. | Cf. Psalm 147 — The selection from Psalm 147 particularly emphasizes God's healing power for the brokenhearted, which takes on special significance in Ma'avar Yabok's context of caring for the sick and dying. | Cf. Psalm 149 — The inclusion of Psalm 149 transitions

honor for all His godly ones. Hallelujah! Let everything that has breath praise the LORD.[1] Hallelujah!

(כתובים) וְעַתָּה הוֹאַלְתָּ לְבָרֵךְ
אֶת בֵּית עַבְדְּךָ[i] לִהְיוֹת לְעוֹלָם
לְפָנֶיךָ כִּי אַתָּה יְיָ בֵּרַכְתָּ וּמְבֹרָךְ
2050 לְעוֹלָם: בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי
יִשְׂרָאֵל אָבִינוּ מֵעוֹלָם וְעַד עוֹלָם:
לְךָ יְיָ הַגְּדֻלָּה וְהַגְּבוּרָה וְהַתִּפְאֶרֶת
וְהַנֵּצַח וְהַהוֹד[ii] כִּי כֹל בַּשָּׁמַיִם
וּבָאָרֶץ לְךָ יְיָ הַמַּמְלָכָה וְהַמִּתְנַשֵּׂא
2055 לְכֹל לְרֹאשׁ: וְעַתָּה אֱלֹהֵינוּ
מוֹדִים אֲנַחְנוּ לָךְ וּמְהַלְלִים לְשֵׁם
תִּפְאַרְתֶּךָ: יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק
וְיִשְׂרָאֵל אֲבֹתֵינוּ שָׁמְרָה זֹאת
לְעוֹלָם לְיֵצֶר מַחְשָׁבוֹת לְבַב עַמֶּךָ
2060 וְהָכֵן לְבָבָם אֵלֶיךָ: וּפְנֵיתָ אֶל
תְּפִלַּת עַבְדְּךָ וְאֶל תְּחִנָּתוֹ יְיָ אֱלֹהָי
לִשְׁמֹעַ אֶל הָרִנָּה וְאֶל הַתְּפִלָּה אֲשֶׁר
עַבְדְּךָ מִתְפַּלֵּל לְפָנֶיךָ: עַתָּה אֱלֹהַי
יִהְיוּ נָא עֵינֶיךָ פְּתֻחוֹת וְאָזְנֶיךָ
2065 קַשֻּׁבוֹת לִתְפִלַּת הַמָּקוֹם הַזֶּה:
וְעַתָּה קוּמָה יְיָ אֱלֹהִים לִנוּחֶךָ

(From the Writings) And now You have been pleased to bless the house of Your servant,[2] that it may continue forever before You; for You, O LORD, have 2280R
blessed, and it is blessed forever. Blessed are You, LORD God of Israel, our Father, from everlasting to everlasting. Yours, O LORD, is the greatness, the power, the glory, the victory, and the majesty;[3] for all that is in heaven and in earth is Yours. Yours 2285R
is the kingdom, O LORD, and You are exalted as head over all. Now, our God, we thank You and praise Your glorious name. O LORD God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, our fathers, keep this forever in the intent of the thoughts of the heart of Your 2290R
people,[A] and prepare their hearts for You. Turn to the prayer of Your servant and to his supplication, O LORD my God, to listen to the cry and to the prayer which Your servant prays before You. Now, my God, I pray that Your eyes be open and Your ears 2295R
attentive to the prayer of this place. Arise now, O LORD God, to Your resting place, You and the ark

[A] Or: "preserve this forever in the formation of the thoughts in the hearts of Your people" — The Hebrew 'לְיֵצֶר' relates to formation or shaping, which could suggest God actively forming the thoughts of His people rather than merely preserving existing thoughts. This alternate translation emphasizes divine agency in shaping human intention.

[1] The concluding verse connects breath (neshamah) with the ability and obligation to praise God. In the context of caring for the ill or dying, this affirms the spiritual value of every breath and moment of life until the very end.

[2] This prayer compilation begins with words from David's prayer after receiving the covenant promise. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, the 'house of Your servant' may be understood both literally (as one's family) and metaphorically (as one's soul).

[3] This declaration of divine attributes serves an important function in the prayer sequence—establishing God's supreme sovereignty before making any requests. This rhetorical structure creates a theological foundation that whatever happens, including illness and death, occurs within God's sovereign domain.

the prayer from supplication to triumphant praise. In Ma'avar Yabok's context, this suggests that even in illness or approaching death, the Jewish tradition encourages praising God and affirming divine justice. | Cf. Psalm 150:6 — Ending with this verse creates a powerful conclusion to the prayer sequence, emphasizing that as long as one has breath, praising God remains possible and appropriate. In Ma'avar Yabok's context for the sick and dying, this carries profound significance about the value of life and breath until the very end.

[i] This opening phrase comes from King David's prayer in I Chronicles 17:27, offering a strong thematic connection to Ma'avar Yabok's focus on divine blessing in times of transition.

[ii] This famous declaration from I Chronicles 29:11 affirms God's sovereignty through five divine attributes. In kabbalistic interpretation, these correspond to specific sefirot (divine emanations): Gedulah/Chesed (Loving-kindness), Gevurah (Strength), Tiferet (Beauty), Netzach (Victory/Eternity), and Hod (Splendor).

אַתָּה וַאֲרוֹן עֻזֶּךָ [i] כֹּהֲנֶיךָ יְיָ אֱלֹהִים
יִלְבְּשׁוּ תְשׁוּעָה וַחֲסִידֶיךָ יִשְׂמְחוּ
בַטּוֹב: עַתָּה עֵינַי יִהְיוּ פְתֻחוֹת
2070 וְאָזְנַי קַשֻּׁבוֹת לִתְפִלַּת הַמָּקוֹם
הַזֶּה: יְיָ אֱלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ הֲלֹא אַתָּה
הוּא אֱלֹהִים בַּשָּׁמַיִם וְאַתָּה מוֹשֵׁל
בְּכָל מַמְלְכוֹת הַגּוֹיִם וּבְיָדְךָ כֹּחַ
וּגְבוּרָה וְאֵין עִמְּךָ לְהִתְיַצֵּב: לֹא
2075 לָכֶם לְהִלָּחֵם בָּזֹאת הִתְיַצְּבוּ עִמְדוּ
וּרְאוּ אֶת יְשׁוּעַת יְהוָה [ii] עִמָּכֶם
יְהוּדָה וִירוּשָׁלַם אַל תִּירְאוּ וְאַל
תֵּחַתּוּ: [iii]

of Your strength. Let Your priests, O LORD God, be clothed with salvation, and let Your faithful ones rejoice in goodness. Now my eyes will be open and my 2300R
ears attentive to prayer made in this place. O LORD God of our fathers, are You not God in heaven? And do You not rule over all the kingdoms of the nations? In Your hand is there not power and might, so that no one is able to withstand You? It is not for you to 2305R
fight in this battle;[1] position yourselves, stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD[A] who is with you, O Judah and Jerusalem! Do not fear or be dismayed.

קְשׁוֹב מַעֲנִי וְאַל תְּפֶן לְמַעְלִי.
2080 תְּפִלָּתִי גְאוֹן צוּרִי וְחַרְבִּי. פְּעוֹל
עִמִּי בְּחַסְדֶּךָ לְרַחֲמִי. לְמַעַנְךָ
צוּר וְלֹא תִטּוֹר לְעָזְבִי. [iv] רְפָאֵנִי
אֱלֹהַי צוּר מְעוֹנִי. אֲשֶׁר גָּדְלְךָ
בְּפִי קוּמִי וְשִׁכְבִי. [v] עֲנֵנִי אֵל כְּדַל

Hear my plea[B] and disregard my transgressions. My prayer is my pride, my Rock and my sword.[C] Act 2310R
with me in Your kindness to show me mercy. For Your sake, O Rock, do not harbor resentment for my abandonment. Heal me, my God, Rock of my dwelling,[D] whose greatness I declare when I rise and

[A] Or: “take your positions, stand firm, and witness the deliverance of the LORD” — This alternate translation emphasizes the active stance of faithful readiness (‘take your positions’) rather than mere positioning, and uses ‘deliverance’ instead of ‘salvation’ to better capture the immediate physical rescue described in the original context of Jehoshaphat’s battle.

[B] Or: “Listen to my response” — The term מַעֲנִי can be translated as “my answer/response” rather than “my plea,” though in the context of prayer, “plea” conveys the supplicatory nature better.

[C] Or: “My prayer is the exaltation of my Rock and my sword” — The syntax allows for reading גְאוֹן as ‘exaltation of’ rather than as the first item in the list. This would make the prayer an exaltation of both God (my Rock) and the speaker’s sword (metaphorically, their strength or defense).

[D] Or: “Rock of my refuge” — מְעוֹנִי can refer to either ‘dwelling’ or ‘refuge’, with the latter

[1] The sudden shift to this declaration from Jehoshaphat’s prayer provides a powerful conclusion to the compilation. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, it offers reassurance to the dying person that they need not struggle against death but can trust in divine salvation.

[i] This verse from II Chronicles 6:41 was originally spoken by Solomon at the dedication of the Temple. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this likely serves as a plea for God’s presence to accompany the soul on its journey, with the ‘ark of strength’ symbolizing divine protection.

[ii] This concluding passage quotes Jehoshaphat’s words from II Chronicles 20:17, spoken when Judah faced overwhelming enemies. In the context of this prayer collection, it likely represents the reassurance that God, not the individual, will fight the ultimate battle with death and spiritual forces.

[iii] Cf. Chronicles (I Chronicles 17:27, 29:10-13; II Chronicles 6:40, 7:15-16, 20:6, 20:17) — The text combines several prayer passages from Chronicles, creating a cohesive liturgical compilation. These are biblical prayers of David, Solomon, and Jehoshaphat, expressing themes of divine sovereignty, kingship, and protection. | Cf. Psalms — While not directly quoting Psalms, this prayer compilation follows the pattern of many psalmic prayers that move from praise of divine attributes to specific requests.

[iv] The phrase ‘do not harbor resentment for my abandonment’ may refer either to the petitioner abandoning God through sin, or to the feeling of being abandoned by God during illness or distress.

[v] This phrase echoes Deuteronomy 6:7, where Israelites are commanded to speak of God’s commandments ‘when you lie down and when you rise up,’ suggesting that the petitioner has been faithful in daily prayers despite current distress.

שׁוֹאֵל בְּבוֹאִי. אֵלַי בְּךָ בָּטַח לְבָבִי: [i]

when I lie down.[1] Answer me, God, as a poor supplicant[2] when I come before You. O Lord, in You alone my heart trusts. 2315R

יאמר יערב עליו שיחי ככתוב לעיל:

One should say "May my speech be pleasing to Him" as written above.

יֵעָרֵב עָלָיו שִׂיחִי אָנֹכִי אֶשְׂמַח בַּיהוָה: אַל תִּתֵּן יְיָ מַאֲוֵי רָשָׁע זְמָמוֹ אַל תְּפַק יָרוּמוּ סֶלָה: שְׁבֹר זְרוֹעַ רָשָׁע וָרָע תִּדְרוֹשׁ רִשְׁעוֹ בַל תִּמְצָא: הַצִּילֵנִי נָא מִיַּד אָחִי מִיַּד עֵשָׂו כִּי יָרֵא אָנֹכִי אֹתוֹ פֶּן יָבֹא וְהִכַּנִי אֵם עַל בָּנִים: וְאַתָּה אָמַרְתָּ הֵיטֵב אֵיטִיב עִמָּךְ וְשַׂמְתִּי אֶת זַרְעֲךָ כְּחוֹל הַיָּם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִסָּפֵר מֵרֹב: תּוֹצִיאֵנִי מֵרֶשֶׁת זוּ טָמְנוּ לִי כִּי אַתָּה מָעֻזִּי: בְּיָדְךָ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי פָּדִיתָה אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת: לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יְהוָה: (ישר הפוך ישר: וכן) לְפִרְקָנָךְ סַבְּרִית יְיָ: מָה תִּשְׁתּוֹחֲחִי נַפְשִׁי וּמָה תֶּהֱמִי עָלָי הוֹחִילִי לֵאלֹהִים כִּי עוֹד אוֹדֶנּוּ יְשׁוּעֹת פָּנַי וֵאלֹהָי: אַתָּה

May my meditation be pleasing to Him; I will rejoice in the LORD. Do not grant, O LORD, the desires of the wicked; do not let their schemes succeed, lest they be exalted. Selah.[A] Break the arm of the wicked and evil; seek out his wickedness until You find none. Deliver me, please, from the hand of my brother, from the hand of Esau, for I fear him, lest he come and strike me, mother with children. Yet You said, "I will surely do good with you, and make your offspring like the sand of the sea,[3] which cannot be counted for multitude." You will bring me out from the net they have hidden for me, for You are my stronghold. Into Your hand I commit my spirit; You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth. For Your salvation I hope, O LORD. (Forward, reverse, forward: and so) For Your redemption I hope, O LORD.[B] Why are you cast down, my soul,[4] and why 2320R 2325R 2330R 2335R

carrying a stronger connotation of protection that may better fit the prayer's theme of seeking divine help.

[A] Or: "Do not grant, O LORD, the wicked one's desires; do not allow his plot to succeed, so they are not exalted. Selah." — This alternate translation emphasizes a singular adversary rather than plural 'wicked ones,' which could be interpreted as referring specifically to the Angel of Death or other negative spiritual forces that Ma'avar Yabok warns might threaten the dying person.

[B] Or: "For Your salvation I have waited, O LORD. (To be recited forward, backward, then forward again:) For Your deliverance I have hoped, O LORD." — This alternative clarifies the instruction for recitation and offers slightly different nuances for the Hebrew and Aramaic terms. The distinction between 'salvation' (ישועה) and 'redemption/deliverance' (פורקן) might be significant in the mystical context of Ma'avar Yabok, where the soul seeks both immediate protection and ultimate spiritual redemption.

[1] This indicates constant devotion throughout the day, from morning to night, echoing traditional Jewish prayer times and the Shema prayer instruction to recite God's words 'when you lie down and when you rise up.'

[2] The Hebrew term דַּל (dal) connotes poverty, weakness, and lowliness, emphasizing the petitioner's humble self-perception before God, a common posture in Jewish prayer during illness or distress.

[3] This quote from Genesis 32:12 is part of Jacob's prayer before meeting Esau, which forms a central biblical motif for Ma'avar Yabok. The prayer strategically incorporates this passage to connect the person's current distress with Jacob's spiritual journey and divine protection.

[4] This self-dialogue from Psalm 42 represents an important therapeutic element in Ma'avar Yabok's

[i] Cf. Psalm 143 — This prayer follows a pattern similar to many psalmic prayers, particularly Psalm 143, which also begins with requests for God to hear the supplicant and not judge their sins. The structural parallels suggest this prayer is modeled on biblical psalms of supplication. | Cf. Psalm 119:170 — The opening phrase echoes biblical prayer language, particularly from Psalms, where petitioners frequently ask God to hear or listen to their pleas. | Cf. Psalm 71:3 — The metaphor of God as 'Rock' (צור) appears throughout this prayer, echoing the common biblical metaphor found in many psalms, where God is described as a rock, indicating stability, protection, and strength.

סֵתֶר לִי מִצַּר תִּצְּרֵנִי רָנֵי פַלֵּט
תְּסוֹבְבֵנִי סֶלָה: מְזִמָּתִי מִיכָאֵל
מִשְּׂמֹאלִי גַּבְרִיאֵל מִלְּפָנַי אוּרִיאֵל
וּמֵאֲחוֹרַי רְפָאֵל וְעַל רֹאשִׁי שְׁכִינַת
2110 אֵל: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בַּיּוֹם בָּרוּךְ יְיָ
בַּלַּיְלָה: בָּרוּךְ יְיָ בְּשָׁכְבֵנוּ בָּרוּךְ
יְיָ בְּקוּמֵנוּ: בָּרוּךְ אֲדֹנָי יוֹם יוֹם
יַעֲמָס לָנוּ הָאֵל יְשׁוּעָתֵנוּ סֶלָה:
יְיָ וְבָרְנוּ יְבָרֵךְ אֶת בֵּית
2115 יִשְׂרָאֵל יְבָרֵךְ אֶת בֵּית אַהֲרֹן: וְהָיָה
שַׁדַּי בְּצָרֶיךָ וְכֶסֶף תּוֹעָפוֹת לָךְ:
שַׁדַּי בָּרְכֵנוּ וְנֵחָיֶה: וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ
יָהּ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ: ג׳
[ii] [i]פעמים

do you moan within me? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him, the salvation of my countenance and my God. You are my hiding place; from trouble You preserve me; with songs of deliverance You surround 2340R
me. Selah. Michael is at my right, Gabriel at my left, Uriel before me, Raphael behind me, and above my head is the Divine Presence of God.[A] Blessed is the LORD by day, blessed is the LORD by night. Blessed is the LORD when we lie down, blessed is the 2345R
LORD when we rise. Blessed is the Lord Adonai day by day; God is our salvation. Selah. The LORD has remembered us; He will bless, He will bless the house of Israel, He will bless the house of Aaron. And the Almighty will be your defender, and silver shall be 2350R
your abundance. May the Almighty bless us, and we shall live. And we will bless the LORD from now and forever. Hallelujah.[1] (3 times)

2120 רִבּוֹן כָּל הָעוֹלָמִים עָשֶׂה רְצוֹנְךָ
בַּשָּׁמַיִם וְתֵן נַחַת רוּחַ לִירֵאֶיךָ
בָּאָרֶץ וּשְׁמַע זַעֲקַת עַבְדְּךָ וְעַמְּךָ
יִשְׂרָאֵל וַעֲשֵׂה מְהֵרָה בַּקָּשָׁתָם
וְהַטּוֹב בְּעֵינֶיךָ עֲשֵׂה: עֲנֵנוּ אָבִינוּ

Master of all worlds,[2] fulfill Your will in heaven and grant satisfaction to those who revere You on earth. 2355R
Hear the cry of Your servant and Your people Israel, and quickly fulfill their request, and do what is good in Your eyes. Answer us, our Father, answer

[A] Or: "On my right is Michael, on my left is Gabriel, before me is Uriel, behind me is Raphael, and above my head is the Divine Presence" — This more literal translation preserves the rhythmic parallelism of the Hebrew formula. This formulation is commonly found in Jewish protective prayers and amulets, and the precise wording was considered important for its effectiveness in creating a spiritual shield.

approach to spiritual care, encouraging the ill person to address their own spiritual distress while maintaining hope in divine salvation.

[1] The instruction to repeat this phrase three times (indicated by פעמים ג׳ at the end of the Hebrew text) reflects the Jewish mystical belief in the power of three-fold repetition to establish spiritual reality and seal a prayer's effectiveness.

[2] This opening address (רִבּוֹן כָּל הָעוֹלָמִים) acknowledges God's sovereignty over multiple worlds or realms, reflecting the kabbalistic worldview prevalent in Ma'avar Yabok that envisions reality as consisting of multiple interconnected spiritual domains.

[i] This instruction at the end indicates that the final line ("And we will bless the LORD from now and forever. Hallelujah") should be recited three times, a common practice in Jewish liturgy for emphasizing important declarations.

[ii] Cf. Psalm 104:34 — This sets the tone for the prayer as one of meditation and spiritual communion with God. | Cf. Psalm 140:8-9 — These verses establish spiritual protection by invoking divine judgment against negative forces. | Cf. Genesis 32:11-12 — This reference to Jacob's prayer before meeting Esau connects directly to Ma'avar Yabok's central metaphor of 'crossing the Yabok' as a spiritual transition. | Cf. Psalm 31:5-6 — Particularly significant as the latter verse was recommended in Ma'avar Yabok for recitation at the moment of death. | Cf. Talmudic angelic formula — This formula creates a spiritual shield around the person reciting it, invoking angelic protection from all directions. In Ma'avar Yabok, this protection is particularly important for the dying person's soul. | Cf. Psalm 42:6, 12 — This creates a dialogue with one's own soul, encouraging hope in God despite current distress—particularly appropriate for someone who is ill or dying. | Cf. Psalm 115:18 — This creates a liturgical closure to the prayer sequence with an affirmation of continued praise.

עֲנֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ מַלְכֵּנוּ עֲנֵנוּ[i] us. Answer us, our King, answer us. Answer us, our
עֶזְרֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ סוֹמְכֵנוּ עֲנֵנוּ Helper, answer us. Answer us, our Supporter, an- 2360R
עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן שִׁמְךָ הַגָּדוֹל הַגִּבּוֹר swer us.[1] Act for the sake of Your great, mighty, and
וְהַנּוֹרָא: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן בְּנֵי בֵיתִי awesome name.[2] Act for the sake of my household
הַתְּלוּיִם עַל רַחֲמֶיךָ: עֲשֵׂה members who depend on Your mercy. Act for the
לְמַעַן הֶבֶל הַתִּנּוֹקוֹת שֶׁל בֵּית sake of the breath of the schoolchildren.[3] Act for the
רַבָּן:[ii] עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן גְּמוּלֵי חָלָב sake of weaned infants who have not sinned. Act for 2365R
שֶׁלֹּא חָטְאוּ: עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן יוֹנְקֵי the sake of nursing babes who have not transgressed.
שָׁלֹא פָּשְׁעוּ:[iii] עֲשֵׂה לְמַעַן Act for the sake of Your abundant mercies and Your
רַחֲמֶיךָ הָרַבִּים וַחֲסָדֶיךָ הַגְּדוֹלִים great kindnesses, and have compassion upon us and
וְרַחֵם עָלֵינוּ וְהוֹשִׁיעֵנוּ: יִהְיוּ save us. May the words of my mouth and the medi-
לְרָצוֹן אִמְרֵי פִי וְהֶגְיוֹן לִבִּי tation of my heart be acceptable before You, LORD, 2370R
לְפָנֶיךָ יְיָ צוּרִי וְגוֹאֲלִי:[iv] my Rock and my Redeemer.

ואם ידמע[v] יאמר קודם יהיו And if one weeps,[4] he should recite these verses be-

[1]This repetitive formula is reminiscent of fast day liturgy, particularly the 'Anenu' prayer recited during communal fasts. The repetition creates a sense of increasing urgency and emotional intensity appropriate for someone in distress.

[2]This phrase echoes the opening of the Amidah prayer's first blessing, which describes God with these three attributes based on Deuteronomy 10:17. Invoking God's name with these specific attributes is considered especially powerful in Jewish prayer tradition.

[3]According to Talmudic tradition, the breath of children studying Torah is considered especially pure and powerful in sustaining the world. This appeal invokes one of the strongest possible merits in Jewish tradition.

[4]This instruction acknowledges the emotional nature of prayer, especially in contexts of illness or approaching death. Ma'avar Yabok shows remarkable sensitivity to the psychological states of those engaged in prayer by providing specific verses for moments of emotional distress.

[i]This repetitive structure creates a rhythmic intensity that reflects the urgency of the prayer. The pairing of 'our Father' with 'our King' reflects the dual relationship with God as both compassionate parent and sovereign ruler, a common motif in Jewish liturgy.

[ii]This refers to the Talmudic concept (Shabbat 119b) that the world is sustained by the breath of children studying Torah, which is considered pure and untainted by sin. Invoking this merit is a powerful plea in Jewish prayer tradition.

[iii]The prayer invokes the merit of innocent children at various developmental stages (schoolchildren, weaned infants, nursing babies), suggesting a progression of increasing innocence and purity. This rhetorical structure strengthens the appeal to divine mercy.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 19:15 — The closing verse is a direct quote from Psalm 19:15, which is commonly used to conclude prayers in Jewish liturgy. Its inclusion here connects this personal supplication to established biblical prayer language. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Ta'anit 16a — The repetitive structure of 'answer us' echoes the form of communal fast day prayers found in the Talmud, which feature similar repetitive patterns to emphasize urgency and create a rhythmic intensity in the prayer. | Cf. Shabbat 119b — The reference to the merit of schoolchildren's breath alludes to the Talmudic teaching that the world is sustained by the breath of children studying Torah, which is considered especially pure and powerful. Invoking this merit suggests the prayer is seeking to access particularly potent spiritual protection. | Cf. Fast day liturgy — The overall structure parallels traditional fast day prayers, particularly in its repetitive appeals, invocation of divine attributes, and mention of innocent children. This positions the prayer within a framework of seeking divine mercy during times of difficulty or danger.

[v]Literally "if he sheds tears" or "if he weeps." This instruction appears in the context of prayer sequences for the sick and dying, providing specific verses to be recited when emotional responses occur during prayer.

לרצון[i] אלו הפסוקים:[ii]

fore “May the words of my mouth be acceptable”:[1]

סוּרוּ מִמֶּנִּי כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן כִּי שָׁמַע
יְהוָה קוֹל בִּכְיִי:[iii] נָדִי סָפַרְתָּה
אָתָּה שִׂימָה דִמְעָתִי בְנֹאדֶךָ[iv] הֲלֹא
בְסִפְרָתֶךָ: יְיָ צְבָאוֹת עִמָּנוּ מִשְׂגָּב
לָנוּ אֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב סֶלָה:[v] יְיָ צְבָאוֹת
אַשְׁרֵי אָדָם בֹּטֵחַ בָּךְ: יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה
הַמֶּלֶךְ יַעֲנֵנוּ בְיוֹם קָרְאֵנוּ:[vi][vii]

Depart from me, all you workers of iniquity,[2] for the LORD has heard the voice of my weeping. You have counted my wanderings;[A] put my tears into Your bottle;[3] are they not in Your book? The LORD of hosts[4] is with us; the God of Jacob is our refuge.[B] Selah. O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in You. Save, O LORD! May the King answer us on the day we call.[5]

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[A] Or: “You have recorded my exile” — The Hebrew ‘nodi’ can refer to wandering but also specifically to exile or banishment, which might be more contextually appropriate in a prayer related to suffering and divine protection.

[B] Or: “is our fortress” — The term ‘misgav’ literally means ‘stronghold’ or ‘fortress’ and carries connotations of military protection, though ‘refuge’ captures the protective aspect well.

[1] This refers to the traditional closing prayer formula from Psalm 19:15 that concludes most Jewish prayer sequences. The instruction indicates these special verses should be inserted just before this standard conclusion.

[2] This opening command for evil forces to depart appears frequently in Ma’avar Yabok’s prayer sequences. In the context of prayers for the sick or dying, it serves to create spiritual protection by banishing negative forces.

[3] The Hebrew ‘nod’ refers to a skin bottle or wineskin. This poetic image suggests that God collects and preserves every tear, emphasizing divine attentiveness to human suffering.

[4] The divine title ‘LORD of hosts’ (YHVH Tzeva’ot) emphasizes God’s command over celestial armies, suggesting divine power over all forces, including those of death.

[5] The final verse shifts from ‘I/my’ to ‘us/our,’ broadening from individual to communal prayer. This reflects the Jewish understanding that individual and communal fates are interconnected.

[i] This refers to the standard prayer conclusion “May the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable before You, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer” (Psalm 19:15), which typically concludes prayer sequences.

[ii] The text appears to be introducing a set of biblical verses to be recited in cases where the person praying becomes emotional and weeps, but it does not continue to list those verses in the segment provided.

[iii] From Psalm 6:8-9, where David confronts his enemies with confidence that God has heard his prayers. In the context of Ma’avar Yabok, this may be directed at spiritual accusers or negative forces that might impede the soul’s journey.

[iv] The image of God collecting tears in a bottle (or wineskin) is a powerful metaphor for divine remembrance and validation of human suffering. This verse from Psalm 56:8 suggests that God preserves the record of human pain.

[v] This term appears frequently in Psalms and is typically understood as a musical direction, possibly indicating a pause for reflection or a musical interlude. It often marks significant theological statements.

[vi] The apostrophes before the final three words create an acrostic יהו״ה (YHYH), closely resembling the divine name. This may be an intentional scribal notation highlighting mystical significance.

[vii] Cf. Psalm 6:8-9 — This reference establishes the prayer as coming from a position of confidence that God has accepted the supplicant’s tears and prayers, thus enemies should depart. | Cf. Psalm 56:8 — The reference to God collecting tears in a bottle is a powerful metaphor for divine remembrance of human suffering, suggesting that no tear is forgotten by God. | Cf. Psalm 46:7, 11 — This reference shifts the prayer from personal lament to communal confidence in divine protection, drawing on the traditional refrain that affirms God’s presence with Israel. | Cf. Psalm 84:12 — This continues the theme of trust in divine protection, moving from communal to individual blessing for those who trust in God. | Cf. Psalm 20:9 — This final verse returns to petition, asking for divine response to prayer. The emphasis on ‘the King’ may have messianic overtones or refer to God as King.

פסוקים מסודרים בסדר אלפא ביתא[i]

Biblical verses arranged in alphabetical order[1]

מכוונים לדעת המסדר[ii] לחיות על שפת האדם תדיר[iii][iv]

directed to[2] keep the Arranger's teaching[3] constantly on one's lips[4]

אליך ה׳ אקרא ואל ה׳ אתחנן:

To You, O LORD, I call, and to the LORD I plead. 2385R

אָנָּא יְיָ הוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא אָנָּא יְיָ הַצְלִיחָה נָּא:[v] וְאַתָּה יְהוָה אַל תִּרְחַק אֱלָוּתִי לְעֶזְרָתִי חוּשָׁה: בְּקָרְאִי עֲנֵנִי אֱלֹהֵי צִדְקִי בַּצָּר הִרְחַבְתָּ לִּי חָנֵּנִי וּשְׁמַע תְּפִלָּתִי: גּוֹל עַל יְיָ דַּרְכֶּךָ וּבְטַח עָלָיו וְהוּא יַעֲשֶׂה: הוֹדִי צַח וְאָדוֹם דָּגוּל

Please, O LORD, save us! Please, O LORD, grant success! And You, O LORD, do not be distant; my strength, hasten to my aid! Answer me when I call, O God of my righteousness; You have relieved me in distress. Be gracious to me and hear my prayer. Commit your way to the LORD[A] and trust in Him, and He will act.[5] My 2390R

[A] Or: "Roll your way upon the LORD" — The Hebrew verb 'gol' literally means 'to roll' and creates a vivid metaphor of rolling one's burdens onto God. While 'commit' captures the theological meaning, the literal translation preserves the physical imagery of the original Hebrew.

[1] This refers to the practice of selecting verses that begin with each successive letter of the Hebrew alphabet to create an acrostic prayer. In Ma'avar Yabok, this alphabetical arrangement has mystical significance, reflecting the belief that the entirety of creation is contained within the Hebrew alphabet. Such alphabetical arrangements were also practical, making prayers easier to memorize for those attending the dying who might be under emotional distress.

[2] The Hebrew 'מכוונים' (mekhavnim) comes from the root meaning 'to direct' or 'to intend,' and is related to the mystical concept of kavvanah (proper intention). It implies conscious spiritual focus rather than casual recitation.

[3] The Hebrew 'דעת המסדר' (da'at hamesader) refers to the knowledge or teaching of 'the Arranger'—likely referring to the author of Ma'avar Yabok or the compiler of these prayer sequences.

[4] This reflects the Jewish mystical understanding that sacred words, when properly pronounced, create spiritual effects in higher realms. Keeping these teachings 'on one's lips' (על שפת האדם תדיר) refers to constant verbalization as a spiritual practice.

[5] The Hebrew phrase 'gol al Adonai darkekha' literally means 'roll your way upon the LORD,' creating a vivid physical metaphor of rolling one's burdens onto God like transferring a heavy load. This imagery is particularly resonant in the context of illness where one feels burdened by physical and spiritual weight.

[i] This brief instruction indicates that biblical verses are to be arranged in alphabetical order, likely creating an acrostic where each verse begins with successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet. This was a common mnemonic device in Jewish liturgy, particularly for prayers related to death and mourning.

[ii] The phrase 'directed to keep the Arranger's teaching' refers to focusing one's intention (kavvanah) on the spiritual teachings of the one who arranged these prayers and rituals.

[iii] Literally 'to be on the lips of man constantly,' this refers to the practice of constantly verbalizing or reciting these teachings, reflecting the kabbalistic emphasis on sacred speech as a vehicle for spiritual transformation.

[iv] Cf. Song of Songs 4:3 — The allusion to lips in Song of Songs connects the act of constant recitation to the mystical understanding of sacred speech as creating beauty in higher realms. | Cf. Deuteronomy 30:14 — This reference reinforces the idea that divine teachings should be internalized and verbalized constantly, not kept at a distance.

[v] This opening line comes directly from Psalm 118:25, which is part of the Hallel liturgy recited on Jewish festivals. Beginning the prayer with this verse establishes a tone of both supplication and praise.

מַרְכָּבָה:[i] הַשְׁלֵךְ עַל יְיָ יְהָבְךָ וְהוּא
יְכַלְכְּלֶךָּ לֹא יִתֵּן לְעוֹלָם מוֹט
לַצַּדִּיק: הַצִּילֵנִי נָא מִיַּד אָחִי מִיַּד
עֵשָׂו כִּי יָרֵא אָנֹכִי אֹתוֹ פֶּן יָבוֹא
וְהִכַּנִי אֵם עַל בָּנִים[ii]: הִרְכַּבְתָּ
אֱנוֹשׁ לְרֹאשֵׁנוּ בָּאנוּ בָאֵשׁ וּבַמָּיִם
וַתּוֹצִיאֵנוּ לָרָוָיָה: וַיְהִי יְיָ מִשְׂגָּב
לַדָּךְ מִשְׂגָּב לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה: זֶה
עָנִי קָרָא וַיְיָ שָׁמַע וּמִכָּל צָרוֹתָיו
הוֹשִׁיעוֹ: חָנֵּנִי יְיָ כִּי אֻמְלַל אָנִי
רְפָאֵנִי יְיָ כִּי נִבְהֲלוּ עֲצָמָי: חָדְלוּ
קֹרוֹבַי וּמְיֻדָּעַי שְׂכֵחוּנִי: טוֹב יְיָ
לַכֹּל וְרַחֲמָיו עַל כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו: יְהִי
חַסְדְּךָ יְיָ עָלֵינוּ כַּאֲשֶׁר יִחַלְנוּ
לָךְ: כִּי אַתָּה תָּאִיר נֵרִי יְיָ אֱלֹהַי
יַגִּיהַּ חָשְׁכִּי: כִּי אָבִי וְאִמִּי עֲזָבוּנִי
וַיהוָה יַאַסְפֵנִי: אוֹהֲבַי וְרֵעַי מִנֶּגֶד
נִגְעִי יַעֲמֹדוּ וּקְרוֹבַי מֵרָחֹק עָמָדוּ:
לָמָּה יְהוָה תַּעֲמֹד בְּרָחוֹק תַּעְלִים
לְעִתּוֹת בַּצָּרָה: מִלְּפָנֶיךָ מִשְׁפָּטִי
יֵצֵא עֵינֶיךָ תֶּחֱזֶינָה מֵישָׁרִים: נֹתֵן
לֶחֶם לְכָל בָּשָׂר כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ:
סוּרוּ מִמֶּנִּי כָּל פֹּעֲלֵי אָוֶן כִּי שָׁמַע
יְיָ קוֹל בִּכְיִי: עוּרָה לָמָּה תִישַׁן
אֲדֹנָי קְקִיצָה אַל תִּזְנַח לָנֶצַח:
עֵינַי כָּל אֵלֶיךָ יְשַׁבֵּרוּ וְאַתָּה נוֹתֵן
לָהֶם אֶת אָכְלָם בְּעִתּוֹ: פּוֹתֵחַ

beloved is radiant and ruddy, distinguished among
ten thousand.[1] Cast your burden[A] upon the LORD
and He will sustain you; He will never allow the 2395R
righteous to be moved.[2] Deliver me, please, from
the hand of my brother, from the hand of Esau,
for I fear him, lest he come and strike me, mothers
with children. You have caused men to ride over
our heads; we went through fire and water, but 2400R
You brought us out to abundance. May the LORD
be a stronghold for the oppressed, a stronghold
in times of trouble.[B] This poor man called, and
the LORD heard him and saved him from all his
troubles. Be gracious to me, O LORD, for I am 2405R
languishing; heal me, O LORD, for my bones are
troubled. My friends and companions stand aloof
from my affliction, and my relatives stand far off.
The LORD is good to all, and His mercy is over
all that He has made. May Your lovingkindness, 2410R
O LORD, be upon us, just as we have hoped in
You. For You light my lamp; the LORD my God
illuminates my darkness. For my father and my
mother have forsaken me, but the LORD will take
me in.[3] My loved ones and friends stand back from 2415R
my plague, and my relatives stand at a distance.
Why, O LORD, do You stand far away? Why do
You hide Yourself in times of trouble? From before
You let my judgment come forth; let Your eyes

[A]Or: "your lot" — The term 'yehavkha' can be understood as 'your burden' but also as 'your lot' or 'what is given to you'—capturing the broader sense of one's circumstances or appointed situation in life.

[B]Or: "for seasons of distress" — The Hebrew 'ittot' can mean 'times' but also specifically 'seasons' or 'appointed times,' suggesting not just random moments of trouble but cyclical or designated periods of difficulty.

[1]This sudden insertion from Song of Songs creates a striking contrast with the surrounding lamentations. In mystical interpretations, this may represent the soul's glimpse of divine beauty even amid suffering, or suggest that physical affliction can sometimes lead to moments of spiritual intimacy.

[2]This verse (Psalm 55:23) reinforces the previous instruction to 'roll' one's way upon the LORD, creating a thematic pair that emphasizes complete reliance on divine support during times of distress.

[3]This verse from Psalm 27:10 addresses the profound isolation often experienced during serious illness. The imagery of divine adoption provides comfort precisely when human relationships seem most distant or strained.

[i]This verse from Song of Songs 5:10 seems somewhat out of place in a prayer otherwise focused on distress and divine protection. In Jewish mystical tradition, Song of Songs is interpreted as an allegory for the relationship between God and Israel, suggesting that even in suffering, the supplicant maintains a loving connection with the divine.

[ii]This is Jacob's prayer from Genesis 32:12, spoken before his anticipated reunion with Esau. The inclusion of this specific verse is significant as it directly connects to the book's title 'Ma'avar Yabok,' which references Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok River during this same episode.

אֶת יָדֶךָ וּמַשְׂבִּיעַ לְכָל חַי רָצוֹן:
צַדִּיק יְיָ בְּכָל דְּרָכָיו וְחָסִיד בְּכָל מַעֲשָׂיו:
קָרוֹב יְיָ לְכָל קֹרְאָיו לְכֹל אֲשֶׁר יִקְרָאֻהוּ בֶּאֱמֶת:
רְצוֹן יְרֵאָיו יַעֲשֶׂה וְאֶת שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם:
שׁוֹמֵר יְיָ אֶת כָּל אֹהֲבָיו וְאֵת כָּל הָרְשָׁעִים יַשְׁמִיד:
תְּהִלַּת יְיָ יְדַבֶּר פִּי וִיבָרֵךְ כָּל בָּשָׂר שֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:
וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ יָהּ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ:
הוֹדוּ לַיְיָ כִּי טוֹב כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ:
מִי יְמַלֵּל גְּבוּרוֹת יְיָ יַשְׁמִיעַ כָּל תְּהִלָּתוֹ:
אַשְׁרֵי שֹׁמְרֵי מִשְׁפָּט עֹשֵׂה צְדָקָה בְכָל עֵת:
זָכְרֵנִי יְיָ בִּרְצוֹן עַמֶּךָ פָּקְדֵנִי בִּישׁוּעָתֶךָ:
חָנֵּנִי יְיָ וְחָנֵּנִי כִּי אֵלֶיךָ אֲיַחֵל הֱיֵה זְרוֹעָם לַבֹּקְרִים אַף יְשׁוּעָתָם בְּעֵת צָרָה:
טוֹב יְיָ לַכֹּל וְרַחֲמָיו עַל כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו:
יוֹדוּךָ יְיָ כָּל מַעֲשֶׂיךָ וַחֲסִידֶיךָ יְבָרְכוּכָה:
כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתְךָ יֹאמֵרוּ וּגְבוּרָתְךָ יְדַבֵּרוּ:
לְהוֹדִיעַ לִבְנֵי הָאָדָם גְּבוּרֹתָיו וּכְבוֹד הֲדַר מַלְכוּתוֹ:
מַלְכוּתְךָ מַלְכוּת כָּל עֹלָמִים וּמֶמְשַׁלְתְּךָ בְּכָל דּוֹר וָדוֹר:
סוֹמֵךְ יְיָ לְכָל הַנֹּפְלִים וְזוֹקֵף לְכָל הַכְּפוּפִים:
עֵינֵי כֹל אֵלֶיךָ יְשַׂבֵּרוּ וְאַתָּה נוֹתֵן לָהֶם אֶת אָכְלָם בְּעִתּוֹ:
פּוֹתֵחַ אֶת יָדֶךָ וּמַשְׂבִּיעַ לְכָל חַי רָצוֹן:
צַדִּיק יְיָ בְּכָל דְּרָכָיו וְחָסִיד בְּכָל מַעֲשָׂיו:
קָרוֹב יְיָ לְכָל קֹרְאָיו לְכֹל אֲשֶׁר יִקְרָאֻהוּ בֶּאֱמֶת:
רְצוֹן יְרֵאָיו יַעֲשֶׂה וְאֶת שַׁוְעָתָם יִשְׁמַע וְיוֹשִׁיעֵם:
שׁוֹמֵר יְיָ אֶת כָּל אֹהֲבָיו וְאֵת כָּל הָרְשָׁעִים יַשְׁמִיד:
תְּהִלַּת יְיָ יְדַבֶּר פִּי וִיבָרֵךְ כָּל בָּשָׂר שֵׁם קָדְשׁוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד:
וַאֲנַחְנוּ נְבָרֵךְ יָהּ מֵעַתָּה וְעַד עוֹלָם הַלְלוּיָהּ: שַׁדַּי
בָּרְכֵנוּ וְנִחְיֶה ג׳ פְּעָמִים[i] כִּי אַתָּה
יָמִים וּשְׁנוֹת חַיִּים וְשָׁלוֹם יוֹסִיפוּ
לִי עִם כָּל עַמּוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל אָמֵן: בָּרוּךְ
יְיָ לְעוֹלָם אָמֵן וְאָמֵן:[ii]

behold what is right. He gives food to all flesh, for 2420R
His steadfast love endures forever. Depart from me,
all evildoers, for the LORD has heard the voice of
my weeping. Awake! Why do You sleep, O Lord?
Arise! Do not reject us forever! The eyes of all
look to You, and You give them their food in due 2425R
season. You open Your hand and satisfy the desire
of every living thing. The troubles of my heart are
enlarged; bring me out of my distresses. The LORD
is near to the brokenhearted and saves the crushed
in spirit. See my affliction and my toil, and forgive 2430R
all my sins. Hear, O LORD, and be gracious to me;
O LORD, be my helper. Bring me out from the net
they have hidden for me, for You are my refuge.
Why are you cast down, O my soul, and why are
you disquieted within me?[1] Hope in God, for I shall 2435R
yet praise Him, the salvation of my countenance
and my God. The LORD has remembered us; He
will bless, He will bless the house of Israel, He will
bless the house of Aaron. We will bless the LORD
from this time forth and forevermore. Hallelujah! 2440R
May Shaddai bless us that we may live (repeat three
times),[2] for length of days, years of life, and peace
shall be added to me, with all His people Israel.

[1]This self-address from Psalm 42:12 represents a crucial turning point in the prayer, where the supplicant shifts from expressions of distress to active self-encouragement. This models how the sick person might engage in similar internal dialogue, acknowledging suffering while consciously redirecting thoughts toward hope.

[2]The instruction to repeat this phrase three times highlights its ritual significance. The divine name 'Shaddai' combined with the explicit request for life suggests this prayer's function in healing contexts. The threefold repetition likely relates to the kabbalistic belief that repetition strengthens the spiritual potency of words.

[i]The instruction to repeat this phrase three times indicates the ritual nature of the prayer. The use of the divine name 'Shaddai' (traditionally associated with protection and blessing) combined with the explicit request for life ('ve-nichyeh') suggests this prayer's function in healing contexts.

[ii]Cf. Psalm 118:25 — This opening identifies the prayer as drawing on Hallel liturgy, immediately establishing a tone of supplication mixed with praise, appropriate for someone in distress but maintaining faith. | Cf. Genesis 32:11-12 — The inclusion of Jacob's prayer before meeting Esau is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok, as the book's title references Jacob's crossing of the Jabbok River during this same episode. This creates a direct connection between the sick person's situation and Jacob's transformative night of struggle before his reunion with Esau. | Cf. Psalm 42:12 — This self-address provides a model for the sick person to engage in similar internal dialogue, acknowledging distress while actively redirecting thoughts toward hope. This verse forms a critical transition from expressions of pain to affirmations of faith. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:10 — In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this reference to Song of Songs introduces a moment of mystical devotion within a prayer otherwise focused on distress and divine protection. It suggests that even in suffering, the sick person can experience a loving connection with the divine, viewing God not just as a protector but as a beloved. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok's central metaphor — The prayer's structure embodies the crossing metaphor of Ma'avar Yabok itself: beginning with urgent pleas for help, moving through acknowledgment of abandonment and isolation, and concluding with expressions of hope and blessing. This models the spiritual journey the sick person is encouraged to make from fear to faith.

Amen. Blessed be the LORD forever! Amen and Amen! 2445R

פרק י״ח

Chapter 18

יערף כמטר לקחי תזל כטל
אמרתי[i] ולכו בני שמעו לי הטיבו
נא מעלליכם כי טוב יפיק רצון
מה׳ ושימו לבבכם על דרכיכם
כי מאן דשיים אורחיה סגי שוי 5R
ותבחרו בחיים הנצחיי׳ ועליכם
המצוה הזאת ועמהן אליכ׳
אישי׳ בני חבורתי אקרא וברוב
רחמכם פנו נא אלי כי אאמיצכם
במו פי יהא רעוא דתהא תפלתי 10R
זכה בעיניכם ותהיה מקום
לזעקתי זאת עשו וחיו כי ישמח
הר ציון תגלנה בנות יהודה
שאו פתחי עולם והתמידו
בכל יום לקום באשמורת 15R
ולהפגין בלילה בדברי שיח רנה
ותפלה[ii] אשר הצעתי לפניכם
במעירי שחר[iii] אשר בנינו
כנטיעים מגודלים בו מנעוריהם
זה כמו עשרה שנים שזכני ה׳ 20R
לעורר בו ישנים בעיר מודי״נה
הל״ו[iv] בצדקתכם תחזיקו ולא
תרפו ממנה כי כן חובה לנו
בכל דבר מצוה ועם שוגי׳
ואוהבי לנום אל תתערבו ותהיו 25R

May my teaching drop like rain, my words flow like dew.[1] Come, my children, listen to me; improve your deeds, for goodness brings favor from the Lord. Set your hearts upon your ways, for one who places his path properly receives proper reward.[A] Choose eternal life, for this commandment is upon you.

And to you, my friends, members of my society, I call. In your great compassion, turn to me, for I will strengthen you with my words. May it be the divine will that my prayer be pure in your eyes and that there be a place for my cry. Do this and live, for Mount Zion will rejoice and the daughters of Judah will be glad. Lift up the eternal gates and persist every day to rise at dawn and to demonstrate at night with words of meditation, song, and prayer that I have set before you in my "Illuminators of Dawn"[B] which we have built like well-tended saplings from their youth. It has been about ten years since the Lord granted me the privilege to awaken those who slumber in this city of Modena.[2] Hold fast to your righteousness and do not let go of it, for such is our obligation in every matter of commandment.

Do not associate with those who err and love to sleep; instead, be united with your peers. Strengthen

[A] Or: "for one who charts his course well receives proportionate reward" — This is an Aramaic expression about proper conduct being rewarded accordingly. The alternate translation maintains the meaning while using more natural English phrasing that captures the proportional relationship between conduct and reward.

[B] Or: "in my dawn prayer society" — From context, this appears to refer to a prayer society or collection that the author established. The term could be translated more functionally rather than as a proper name.

[1] The author begins with Moses' words from Deuteronomy 32:2, establishing a connection between his own teaching and biblical authority.

[2] The text confirms that the author led this prayer society in Modena, Italy, for approximately ten years.

[i] This is a direct quote from Deuteronomy 32:2, from Moses' song, using the metaphor of rain and dew to describe the gentle but penetrating nature of divine teaching.

[ii] The term להפגין (to demonstrate) is unusual in a prayer context, suggesting a public or collective demonstration of piety through nighttime prayer, not just private devotion.

[iii] "Me'irei Shachar" (Illuminators of Dawn) appears to be the name of the author's prayer society in Modena, focused on early morning devotions. This provides important historical context about the author's communal role.

[iv] This confirms the author's presence in Modena, Italy, and his leadership role in a prayer society there for approximately ten years.

לאחדים עם בני גילכם וחזקו
ואמצו יחד ואיש לאחיו יאמר
חזק ונתחזקה בעד עמנו וערי
אלהינו ואם תאבו דיתקיים
צוותא דלכון לעלמין השמרו
לכם פן אל יכנס אחד מכם
בתחום חבירו ולא לדברי חבירו
פן חם ושלום יפיק מיניה חורבא
בארבעה אבות נזיקין וחניקא
של סמ״ך מ״ם יקבוץ און זה
לו לידון דינא דגרמי ולגרום
חניקא מאחד לחבריה כדרכן
של נמלים בעידנא דאיתערבב
להון עפרא דחוריהון דין עם דין
דחנקי דא לדא כאשר הביא בעל
שלטי הגבורים במועד קטן פרק
קמא על משנת צדין את האישות
ואפ״לא דאיהו דין שיש לו רום
נמוכא דגני בבית אפל לשוייה
חרפ״א ודאי אסור[i] שמעו נא
בנים מוסר אב [ii]

and encourage one another, and let each man say to his brother, "Be strong!" and let us strengthen ourselves for the sake of our people and the cities of our God. If you desire that your fellowship endure forever, guard yourselves lest any of you enter his fellow's domain or interfere with his fellow's words, lest—Heaven forbid—this leads to destruction through the four principal categories of damages.[1] The suffocation of Samael[A] will gather this iniquity to himself to judge causative damages and to cause one to suffocate his fellow, just as ants do when their nest's earth is disturbed, strangling one another,[2] as explained by the author of Shiltei Gibborim in Moed Katan, first chapter, on the Mishnah "Trapping moles." And certainly one who possesses elevated status should not lie in a dark house to make a mockery—this is surely forbidden. Listen, my children, to a father's instruction.

ולכת אמיץ הנה אל שדי תתחננו

And to the strong company,[3] behold, you shall en-

[A] Or: "The strangulation of the Evil One" — The abbreviation סמ״ך מ״ם (samekh mem) is a common euphemism for Satan/Samael, often used to avoid directly naming the evil force. This alternate translation conveys the meaning without using the name Samael, which might be more appropriate for some audiences.

[1] This refers to the rabbinic categorization of damages in Jewish law (Bava Kamma 1:1): ox, pit, fire, and man. The author is using a legal framework to warn against spiritual harm within the community.

[2] This vivid metaphor compares community conflict to ants that attack each other when their nest is disturbed. The author cites a rabbinic commentary (Shiltei Gibborim) on Mishnah Moed Katan to strengthen this unusual comparison.

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'לכת אמיץ' refers to the tight-knit community or brotherhood the author is addressing, possibly members of his prayer society.

[i] This phrase contains wordplay and is difficult to translate precisely. It refers to someone of high status ("elevated low one"—a paradoxical term) who should not lower themselves by sleeping in a dark house to make mockery. This may be a warning against distinguished members degrading themselves through improper behavior.

[ii] Cf. Deuteronomy 32:2 — The author opens with Moses' words to establish authority and continuity with the biblical tradition, positioning his own teaching as divinely inspired instruction. | Cf. Proverbs 8:35 — The author draws on this biblical wisdom tradition to emphasize that following his instructions leads to eternal life, elevating his guidance to the level of divine wisdom. | Cf. Psalms 48:12 — This reference connects the author's instructions to biblical promises of joy and divine favor, suggesting that following his guidance will lead to communal rejoicing. | Cf. Mishnah Moed Katan — This reference to a relatively obscure halakhic discussion demonstrates the author's rabbinic learning while using the metaphor of disturbed ants to warn against interfering in others' domains within the prayer society. | Cf. Psalm 24:7 — This biblical allusion frames the daily prayer practice as a way of opening spiritual gateways, suggesting that the author's prayer society facilitates divine entry into the world through their dawn devotions.

בבקר השכם[i] ואם כסף תועפות
ישעה מכם לפאר ליוצריכם
ברוב עם אז על שד״י תתענגו
כי לא ימנע טוב להולכים
בדמ״ים וכל מי שיתן למצוה
אינו מחסר את נכסיו[ii] שכן
נאמר כי נר מצוה ותורה אור
כפי דרשת חכמינו ז״ל בשמות
רבה פ׳ ל״ו והקב״ה למעשה
ידיו יכסוף שיהללום בשערים
מעשיהם עוד אמרו בויקרא רבה
פ׳ ה׳ לפי מתנתך מרחיבין לך
ואם תקיימו דברי הזקן אבינו
יעקב בהפריש מעשרות ממתנת
ידיכם בכך יהיו בידכם מורמים
ומופרשים המעות לשם מצוה
ומהם תזכו לעניים המחזיקים
בידכם במצוה זו ובזה תשחקו
לסוס ולרוכבו[iii] ותשגיא פעלכם
וחתת לא תיראו ותשואות נוגש
לא תשמעו ותקחו במצוה זו
מוסר השכל בהמת לפרקים
יחד דברי אשר התחננתי בסוף
המעירי שחר הנזכר למעלה
להקיץ לב נרדמים דהשתא ייתו
יומי דאריכי וקטיני ונינם טובא
ושינה מתוקה גורמת למיתה
דחוקה ומרה[iv] רחמנא לצלן

treat the Almighty in the early morning,[1] and if 45R
abundant silver is requested from you to glorify your
Creator with a multitude of people, then you shall
delight in the Almighty. For He does not withhold
good from those who walk in[2] purity,[A] and whoever
gives to a commandment does not diminish his pos- 50R
sessions, as it is said, “For a commandment is a lamp
and the Torah is light,” according to our Sages of
blessed memory’s interpretation in Exodus Rabbah,
chapter 36. And the Holy One, blessed be He, yearns
for the works of His hands, that their deeds should 55R
be praised in the gates. They further said in Levi-
ticus Rabbah, chapter 5, “According to your gift, they
expand for you.” And if you fulfill the words of our
elder father Jacob by separating tithes from the gift
of your hands, in this way the funds will be in your 60R
hands, set aside and designated for the sake of the
commandment. Through them, you will merit [to
help] the poor who strengthen your hands in this
commandment. And with this, you will laugh at
the horse and its rider, and your work will increase, 65R
and you will not see terror, and you will not hear
the demands of the taskmaster. And you will take
from this commandment moral instruction for your
beasts occasionally, together with my words[B] which
I pleaded at the end of “Illuminators of Dawn” men- 70R
tioned above, to awaken the hearts of the slumber-
ing. For now, the days that are long and short will

[A] Or: “blood-offerings” — The term דמ״ים literally means ‘bloods’ and could refer to sacrificial offerings or monetary payments rather than moral purity. In certain contexts, it refers to blood sacrifices, which were replaced by prayer and charity after the Temple’s destruction.

[B] Or: “like animals at intervals, combined with my words” — This phrase is grammatically complex. An alternative reading could understand ‘בהמת’ not as ‘your beasts’ but as ‘like animals,’ suggesting that the community should periodically gather like a herd to hear the author’s teachings.

[1] The author places special emphasis on early morning prayer, consistent with his leadership of the ‘Me’irei Shachar’ (Illuminators of Dawn) prayer society mentioned in the memory notes.

[2] The term דמ״ים could be interpreted multiple ways. While literally meaning ‘bloods,’ in this context it likely refers to ritual purity or moral integrity, though it may also allude to sacrificial offerings.

[i] The emphasis on early morning prayer reflects the kabbalistic belief that divine mercy is more accessible during the morning hours when the attribute of Chesed (loving-kindness) dominates.

[ii] This reflects the rabbinic concept that charitable giving doesn’t diminish wealth but rather increases it—a paradoxical principle found throughout Jewish ethical literature.

[iii] A biblical allusion to the Song of the Sea (Exodus 15:1-21) where the Israelites celebrated God’s victory over Pharaoh’s army. Here it’s repurposed to suggest that charitable giving provides victory over spiritual enemies.

[iv] This reflects the kabbalistic concern that excessive physical comfort (represented by sleep) can lead to spiritual neglect and ultimately spiritual death. The metaphor of sleep as spiritual complacency is common in mystical literature.

כאשר הובא במרגניתא דרבי מאיר ומשכילי עם מפני חרבות ירושלים נדדו שינה מעיניהם. ובזה תעשו סוכה לשומר שיבא וישמר אתכם [i]

come,[1] and they sleep much, and sweet sleep causes constricted and bitter death, God save us, as was brought in the "Pearl of Rabbi Meir." And the wise of the people, because of the destruction of Jerusalem, have banished sleep from their eyes. And with this, you will make a shelter for the guardian[2] who will come and protect you.

75R

דטוביה דהוא בביתיה טוביה דהוא בלויתיה ואם אנ״י והו״א כאן הכל כאן ואיש באחיו תדובקו תתלכדו ולא תתפרדו. (ורו״ח אחר״ת לא יבא ביניכם) ואחריתכם תשגא מאד ועוף השמים יוליך את קולכם כדתרגם יונתן בפסוק זה כי מלאך פלוני מכריז בכל יומא מן שמיא על טורא דחורב[ii] ומהלך קליה בכל עלמא ואליהו כהנא רבא אזיל ופרח באויר שמיא בנשרא מד׳ גפין[iii] ומחוי מילין דמתעבדין בטימורתא לכל דיירי עלמא ותהיו ממצדיקי הרבים ומאן דאגר גינא עילאה

Good is he who is in his house, good is he who is in his company.[3] And if I and He are here, all is here.[4] Cleave to one another, unite, and do not separate. (And let no alien spirit come between you.) Your latter end will grow exceedingly great, and the bird of the heavens will carry your voice, as Jonathan translated this verse: "For a certain angel proclaims every day from heaven upon Mount Horeb, and his voice travels throughout the world, and Elijah the High Priest goes and flies through the air of heaven like an eagle with four wings, and reveals deeds done in secret to all the inhabitants of the world." And you shall be among those who bring merit to the many, and whoever cultivates this supernal garden eats the reward of the celestial birds.[5] Write these words upon your hearts, for upon them I will make

80R

85R

90R

95R

[1] This appears to refer to the changing seasons, suggesting the passage of time and the approach of judgment, adding urgency to the author's spiritual exhortations.

[2] This metaphor draws on the biblical concept of the sukkah (temporary dwelling) but repurposes it as spiritual protection. The guardian likely refers to divine protective forces activated through proper observance and charity.

[3] This appears to be a proverbial expression emphasizing the value of both solitary spiritual practice and communal worship or study.

[4] This likely refers to a rabbinic saying about divine presence, suggesting that when God ('He') and the individual ('I') are spiritually connected, everything necessary is present.

[5] This metaphorical expression suggests that those who engage in spiritual cultivation (through study and practice) will receive heavenly rewards, with 'celestial birds' possibly representing angels or divine messengers.

[i] Cf. Exodus Rabbah 36 — The author cites this text to support the claim that giving to commandments (mitzvot) does not diminish one's wealth but rather increases it through divine blessing. | Cf. Leviticus Rabbah 5 — This reference reinforces the author's central argument that charitable giving results in expanded blessings, creating a direct relationship between generosity and divine abundance. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar (Illuminators of Dawn) — The author refers to his own previous work or prayer collection, which contained similar exhortations to spiritual vigilance and charitable giving. | Cf. Marganita d'Rabbi Meir (Pearl of Rabbi Meir) — The author cites this text to warn against spiritual complacency, linking excessive sleep to spiritual and physical death. | Cf. Proverbs 6:23 — This verse is used to establish the metaphorical framework that mitzvot provide spiritual illumination and protection, justifying the emphasis on charitable giving.

[ii] This refers to a mystical tradition that an angel makes proclamations daily from Mount Horeb (Sinai), suggesting that spiritual revelations continue to emanate from the site of the original Torah revelation.

[iii] This describes Elijah the prophet as a 'High Priest' flying through the heavens like an eagle with four wings, representing his role as a cosmic messenger who reveals hidden deeds. The four wings may correspond to the four letters of the divine name or the four worlds in Kabbalistic cosmology.

דא אכיל אגר דצפרין עלאין
וכתבו על לבכם את הדברים
האלה כי על פיהם אכרות עמכם
100 ברית. ושיתו לבכם לחילה לעת
אשר ינתק מאהל אדם מבטחו
מעה״ז והצעידהו לעבד מלך
הכושי בבלהות[i] על דרך שאמרו
חז״ל במס׳ ברכות אם יראה
105 אדם שיצרו מתגבר עליו יזכיר
לו יום המיתה. ואמרו בזהר פ׳
בשלח אי לעילא אית ליה לבר
נש מרי דבבו לתתא אוף הכי
ודאי הוא צר דהוא צר לעילא
110 צר לתתא ועל פי עצת חכמים
זו. עוד זאת אדרש מכם ותזל
אמרתי כמוכן על התלמידים
הקטנים בני גילי שעדיין לא
שמשו כל צרכן שיביעו ידברו
115 לפחות זמן מה פעם א׳ בשנה
יהיה לכם שיח ושיג בארבעה הנה
קטני ארץ מאמרותי חלו כי הם
״מורים ״עבודת ״ברכה ״רמה
ראשי תיבות מעב״ר ששם ינוחו
120 ה״יחוד וה״ברכה והק״דושה
ראשי תיבות י״בק[ii] ויזכו בכל
קריאה לקנות להם רוח נשברה
כי בזה יחרדו מאימת מות
ויכניעו כח המנגד המתגבר
125 עליהם ובעקיפין ותסקופין אתי
לגבייהו[iii] ובתחבולה זו יעשו

a covenant with you.

Set your hearts to its strength, for the time when man's security is severed from his tent in this world,[1] and it leads him to serve the Cushite king in terrors, as our Sages of blessed memory said in 100R
Tractate Berakhot: "If a person sees that his evil inclination is overwhelming him, he should remind himself of the day of death." And they said in the Zohar, Parashat Beshalach: "If a person has an enemy above, he surely has one below, for what 105R
causes trouble above causes trouble below." And according to this advice of the Sages.[A]

Furthermore, I ask this of you, and may my words flow like prepared [oil] concerning the young students of my age group who have not yet served [their 110R
teachers] sufficiently, that they should speak and discuss for at least some time, once a year, about these four small ones of the earth from my discourses, for they are: "Teaching," "Service," "Blessing," "Exalted"—the acronym forming "Ma'avar" (מעב״ר), for 115R
there rest the "Unification," the "Blessing," and the "Holiness"—the acronym forming "YaBoK" (י״בק). And may they merit with every reading to acquire for themselves a broken spirit,[2] for through this they will tremble with the fear of death and subdue the 120R
opposing force that strengthens against them, approaching them indirectly and through thresholds, and with this strategy they will wage war against it, for this despicable one is only completed through the sins of mankind,[B] and it seeks to join with the side 125R

[A] Or: "And you should follow this advice of the Sages." — The original translation is more literal, but the alternate is more directive and better captures the instructional tone of the passage, which is providing guidance to the readers.

[B] Or: "for this vile entity only gains power through the sins of mankind" — While the original translation is more literal, the alternate better conveys the kabbalistic concept being expressed about how negative spiritual forces gain strength through human sin.

[1] This is a poetic reference to death, describing it as the moment when one's connection to physical existence ('tent') is cut off.

[2] This phrase alludes to Psalm 51:17, 'The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise.' It represents the spiritual state of humility and contrition that the author believes will come from studying his work.

[i] This metaphorical reference to the 'Cushite king' likely represents the Angel of Death or demonic forces that rule in the realm of terror and darkness.

[ii] Here the author reveals the mystical significance of the book's title through two acronyms: Ma'avar (מעב״ר) standing for 'Teaching, Service, Blessing, Exalted' and YaBOK (י״בק) representing 'Unification, Blessing, and Holiness.' This demonstrates how the title encodes the book's spiritual purpose.

[iii] This phrase uses technical kabbalistic terminology to describe how negative spiritual forces approach humans indirectly and through thresholds, suggesting that spiritual dangers often come through subtle, indirect approaches rather than direct confrontation.

עמו מלחמה דלא אשתלם מנוולא
דא אלא בחוביהון דבני נשא
ובעי לאשתפא בסטר גבורה
למיגח קרבא עם יצר הרע. ועוד
בהגיון זה יראה לעיניהם איזה
דרושים המלהבים לב האדם
להיות מהיר וזריז לעבודת
מלכו ויקנו יראת שמים ואהבה
ובזה יזכו לתפנוקי מלכא ולא
תאונה אליהם רעה דא לילית
ונגע לא יקרב באהליהם דאינון
שאר מזיקין ח״ו ואם כה יעשו
ויקנו בנפשם קדושה [i]

of Gevurah to wage war with the evil inclination.

Moreover, through this contemplation, they will see before their eyes certain discourses that inflame the human heart to be swift and diligent in the service of their King, and they will acquire fear of Heaven and love, and thereby merit the delights of the King. No evil shall befall them—this is Lilith—and no plague shall come near their tents—these are other harmful spirits,[A] God forbid. And if they do this and acquire holiness in their souls.

יהיה כל א׳ מהם אהוב למעלה
ונחמד למטה. ויזכה לטוב
הצפון לצדיקים היושבים בצל
האילן הנובע גולות ברכות מים
חיים ונופל על ראש כל צדיק
וצדיק. וכל הזוכה שנופל עליו
הטל ההוא[ii] הולך ועומד בשער
המזרחי של ג״ע שלפני גנת

Each of them will be beloved above and desired below. And they will merit the goodness hidden away for the righteous who sit in the shadow of the tree[1] that wells forth springs of blessings[B2] of living waters,[C] which falls upon the head of each and every righteous person. And whoever merits that this dew falls upon them goes and stands at the eastern gate of the Garden of Eden that is before

[A] Or: "namely Lilith—and no plague shall approach their dwellings—referring to other harmful spiritual entities" — The alternate translation clarifies the referents more explicitly, making it clearer that the text is identifying specific spiritual dangers.

[B] Or: "that causes spheres of blessing to flow as living waters" — The Hebrew term 'gulot' (גולות) can refer to spherical objects or bubbling springs. This alternate translation emphasizes the spherical imagery, which might better capture the kabbalistic concept of divine emanations as circular or spherical flows.

[C] Or: "that causes spheres of blessing to flow as living waters" — The Hebrew term 'gulot' (גולות) can refer to spherical objects or bubbling springs. This alternate translation emphasizes the spherical imagery, which might better capture the kabbalistic concept of divine emanations as circular or spherical flows.

[1] The image of sitting "in the shadow" (בצל) of a tree combines protection, refreshment, and divine closeness. It echoes Song of Songs 2:3, "I delighted to sit in his shadow," which kabbalistic literature interprets as the soul finding refuge in divine presence.

[2] The Hebrew uses a complex metaphor combining imagery of a tree with that of a spring ("הנובע גולות ברכות"), creating a picture of a tree that somehow produces flowing water. This combines biblical imagery from Psalms 1:3 (tree planted by streams of water) with Proverbs 10:11 (mouth of the righteous is a wellspring of life).

[i] Cf. Zohar Beshalach — This reference establishes a kabbalistic framework for understanding spiritual opposition, supporting the author's guidance about combating negative forces through spiritual practices | Cf. Talmud Berakhot — This reference serves to ground the mystical guidance in traditional rabbinic wisdom, showing how contemplation of mortality can serve as a spiritual technique for self-improvement | Cf. Ecclesiastes 10:20 — The author uses this reference to suggest that righteous actions have cosmic significance, being announced throughout spiritual realms by angelic messengers | Cf. Daniel 12:3 — This biblical allusion suggests that those who follow the author's guidance will not only benefit themselves but help others achieve spiritual elevation, thus meriting special eschatological rewards

[ii] This reference to dew (tal) falling on the righteous has deep mystical significance in Jewish thought. The "dew of resurrection" (tal ha-techiyah) is believed to revive the dead, and here it serves as a metaphorical connection between this world and the World to Come.

אגוז[i] שהוא היכל לפני ולפנים
בג״ע ושם עומד ומשתחוה לפני
ענן כבודו של הקב״ה והקב״ה
שואל והוא משיב כל מה שלמד
בעוה״ז[ii] וכן עושה לכל צדיק
וצדיק. אח״כ ענן הכבוד בא
ועומד על אילן החיים שהוא
באמצע הגן[iii] הנותן ריח שמאותו
ריח הוא חיים לכל הצדיקים
אשר שם. והענן סר והצדיקים
באים ומשתחוים לפני אור זוהר
כבודו למעלה בשמי השמים.
אשרי העם שככה לו אשרי העם
שה׳ אלהיו. יהי כבוד ה׳ לעולם
ישמח ה׳ במעשיו. ברוך ה׳
לעולם אמן ואמן:[iv]

the Garden of Nuts, which is a chamber within the innermost part[A] of the Garden of Eden. There they stand and bow before the cloud of glory of the Holy One, blessed be He, and the Holy One, blessed be He, asks and they respond with all that they have learned in this world. And so He does for each and every righteous person. Afterward, the cloud of glory comes and stands over the Tree of Life,[1] which is in the middle of the garden, giving off a fragrance from which comes life for all the righteous who are there. And the cloud departs, and the righteous come and bow before the light of His radiant glory above in the highest heavens. Happy is the people for whom it is so,[2] happy is the people whose God is the LORD. May the glory of the LORD endure forever; may the LORD rejoice in His works. Blessed be the LORD forever, amen and amen.

145R 150R 155R 160R

[A] Or: "a sanctuary within the Holy of Holies" — The Hebrew phrase 'lifnei v'lifnim' uses Temple terminology that specifically refers to the Holy of Holies, the innermost sanctuary of the Temple. This alternate makes the Temple parallel more explicit, though it's somewhat interpretive in this context.

[1] This parallels the cloud of divine presence that stood over the Tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 40:34-38), creating a connection between that historical manifestation of divine presence and the eschatological experience described here.

[2] This concluding phrase comes from Psalm 144:15, followed by "Happy is the people whose God is the LORD," forming a traditional closing for liturgical passages. The author uses biblical verses to create a seal of authority for the mystical vision just described.

[i] "Garden of Nuts" (Ginat Egoz) alludes to Song of Songs 6:11 and is a common kabbalistic metaphor for esoteric wisdom. In kabbalistic literature, the hard shell of the nut represents external barriers that must be broken to access inner mystical truths.

[ii] This passage reflects the rabbinic concept that one's Torah learning is the primary currency of the World to Come, where souls are examined on what they studied in life. It appears in various midrashic sources including Shabbat 31a, where the first question one is asked in heavenly judgment is "Did you set fixed times for Torah study?"

[iii] The Tree of Life positioned in the center of the garden directly parallels the biblical Garden of Eden (Genesis 2:9) and represents the central axis of divine emanation in kabbalistic cosmology.

[iv] Cf. Song of Songs 6:11 — The text draws on the Garden of Nuts (Ginat Egoz) imagery from Song of Songs, which became a central metaphor in kabbalistic literature for the esoteric dimensions of Torah. Just as a nut has a hard shell and sweet interior, mystical wisdom requires breaking through external barriers to access deeper truth. | Cf. Zohar — This passage closely parallels Zoharic descriptions of the Garden of Eden, particularly in its imagery of the righteous standing before divine glory, experiencing the fragrance of the Tree of Life, and the examination of Torah learning. The hierarchical structure of the Garden with chambers within chambers is distinctly Zoharic. | Cf. Psalms 144:15 — The author incorporates this biblical verse as a liturgical conclusion, affirming that the mystical vision he has described represents the ultimate happiness for Israel. By closing with scriptural quotation, he gives traditional authority to his mystical teachings. | Cf. Genesis 2:9 — The positioning of the Tree of Life "in the middle of the garden" directly echoes the biblical Garden of Eden. The author is establishing a parallel between the primordial paradise and the eschatological reward for the righteous, suggesting that the afterlife represents a restoration of humanity's original perfect state.

Part IV

Supplementary discourses

Discourse 9

אמרי נעם / Sayings of Sweetness

פרק א׳ — Chapter 1

בשם ה׳ מאמר ה[i] [ii]

In the Name of the Lord, Discourse Five[1]

מתוק לנפש ומרפא לעצם והוא תוספת בעקר ספר מעבר יבק:[iii] [iv]

Sweet to the soul and healing to the bone, which is a supplement to the main book[2] Ma'avar Yabok.

אמר החכם אין לך דבר שאין לו גדר. אמרו לו מהו הגדר 5R

The sage said, "There is nothing without its proper boundary." They asked him, "What is this

[1] This marks the beginning of the fifth discourse of Aaron Berechia of Modena's Ma'avar Yabok. The book is structured into multiple discourses (ma'amarim), each addressing different aspects of care for the dying, burial practices, and the soul's journey after death. The fifth discourse likely follows the fourth discourse entitled 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' (Cloud of Incense Prayer), which focused on prayer as a substitute for Temple incense offerings.

[2] This phrase indicates that what follows is an additional section that was likely added to Ma'avar Yabok after its initial composition, perhaps to address topics that were not fully covered in the original text.

[i] This phrase marks the beginning of the fifth discourse (Ma'amar Hey) of Ma'avar Yabok. Each discourse in the book corresponds to different aspects of spiritual preparation for death and the afterlife, with the title referencing 'In the Name of the Lord,' indicating the sacred nature of what follows.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The title 'Ma'avar Yabok' (Crossing of the Jabbok) refers to Jacob's biblical crossing of the Yabok River, which serves as a metaphor for the soul's transition from this world to the next—a central theme of the book.

[iii] The title "Ma'avar Yabok" (Crossing of the Jabbok) refers to Jacob's biblical crossing of the Yabok River (Genesis 32), which serves as a central metaphor for the soul's transition from this world to the next throughout the book.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — This text identifies itself as a supplement or addition to the main work "Ma'avar Yabok" (Crossing of the Jabbok), a comprehensive Jewish guidebook on death, dying, and the afterlife authored by Aaron Berechia of Modena. The metaphor of the Jabbok crossing symbolizes the soul's transition from this world to the next.

אמר הבט״חון[i] ועל פי עצה
זאת בבטחה והשקט היה לי
להתגדר במלאכתי זאת. ברם
היו ידי חמומות ונפשי נבהלה
מאד להפיק רצון הנפטרים
וערומים בדעת וחכמה אשר
עצתם עלי נמהרה[ii] כאשר בא
בהקדמה ומרצוני ודעתי שבקית
ופטרית כמה דרושים אשר היו
באים לרגל המלאכה אשר לפני
וכמעט כפלים לתושיה והנה
עתה אחר גמר הדפסת הספר
רוח מלפני חלף להרים מקצת
מהם[iii] שנים שלשה גרגירים
באמר״ים נעימ״ים אשר יחדו
יהיו תאומים עם ארבעה מאמרים
ראשונים אשר פעם זקנים יקחו
לימא מילתא במטעמא מאשר
חכמים יגידו במסכת שמחות
ומראים פני הראות בקצת לנהרי
נחלי דבש וחמאה המוכנים
למבלים ימיהם בטוב ושנותם
בנעימים[iv] והעובר ביתו העליון
וגם אושפיזיה תחתון הוא הבוצע
בצע. ומה יעשה אדם ויתעשר
ישא ויתן באמונה. עוד נכלל
בהה איך מוח עצמות ישוקה
מאשר תפלתו זכה לפני קינו
על כל צרה שלא תבא וטעם
הנהגת העולם בדין. ולמה למות
תוצאות ופירוש קצת פסוקי
יחוד ואביזרייהו. אחי זבן לך
הא ולא תידול וזיל אברי נפשך
בהון. והן קלותי וזלתי. קפוץ
קני מינייהו כי הא סקא והא
סלעא והא סאתא קום כיל ואכול
ויערב ויבסם לך שכן דרכה
של רעיה תמה למסר מלה

boundary?" He replied, "Trust." And guided by this counsel, I was able to engage in this work of mine with confidence and tranquility. However, my hands grew hot and my soul was greatly troubled to fulfill the wishes of the departed and those 10R
shrewd in knowledge and wisdom, whose counsel concerning me was hasty, as mentioned in the introduction. Of my own will and judgment, I abandoned and dismissed many discourses which would have accompanied the work before me, almost 15R
doubling its substance. And now, after completing the printing of the book, a spirit passed before me to raise up some of them—two or three kernels of pleasant sayings—which together will be twins with the first four discourses, from which elders 20R
will occasionally take a substantive word from what the sages declare in Tractate Semachot, showing glimpses in part of rivers and streams of honey and butter prepared for those who spend their days in goodness and their years in pleasantness. One 25R
who troubles his upper house and also his lower dwelling place is the one who cuts off gain. And what should a person do to become wealthy? Let him deal honestly in business. Also included in this is how the marrow of bones is refreshed when 30R
one's prayer is pure before his Maker concerning any trouble that might come, and the reason for God's governance of the world through judgment, and why death has consequences, along with explanations of certain verses of unification and their accessories. 35R
My brother, purchase this and do not hesitate; go and restore your soul with them. Indeed, I have made myself insignificant and lowly. Jump up and acquire them, for here is a measure, here is a coin, and here is a seah—arise, measure, eat, and may it 40R
be sweet and fragrant to you, for such is the way of a perfect shepherd to deliver a word to her mighty one. And may the good come and receive from these

[i]The author opens with a philosophical principle that everything has its proper boundary or limitation, which he identifies as 'trust' (bitachon). This fundamental concept of trust in divine providence frames his approach to writing about death and mourning.

[ii]The phrase suggests that the author feels an obligation to fulfill the wishes of both the deceased and living scholars who urged him to write this work. This creates a dual responsibility—to honor the dead and to satisfy the expectations of the learned living.

[iii]This reveals that the present text is a supplementary addition composed after the main book was already printed. The phrase 'a spirit passed before me' echoes biblical language (Job 4:15) and suggests divine inspiration for including this additional material.

[iv]This metaphor of 'rivers of honey and butter' for the righteous draws on biblical imagery (Job 20:17) to describe spiritual rewards. The author is suggesting that proper preparation for death, as outlined in his book, leads to these divine pleasures in the afterlife.

לברזיליה.[i] ובא יבא טוב ויקבל מטוב אמרי נועם אלה ולפרקים חלקתיו אף עשיתיו במאמרים הקודמים להפסקת ענייני מאמר חמישי הלז להבדיל בין ענין לענין וליתן ריוח ביניהם קחנו נא עם שאר הספר ושים עיניך עליו כי תרבה עליך תחנונים וחנא מאוצר הגדול ובו תעדה גאון וגובה והוד והדר תלבש ועטישותיך תחל אור וכשלב אדם יחשב דרכו כפי מחשבתו הטהורה ה׳ יכין צעדו:[iii ii]

pleasant sayings. I have divided it into sections and fashioned it like the previous discourses, separating the topics of this fifth discourse to distinguish one matter from another and to provide space between them. Please take it along with the rest of the book and set your eyes upon it, for it will increase your supplications and grace from the great treasury. With it you will adorn yourself with majesty and loftiness, and clothe yourself with splendor and glory, and your speech will shine forth light. And as a person considers his way according to his pure thought, the LORD will establish his steps." 45R 50R 55R

דרושים קצרים בכמות ורבי האיכות[iv] במנוחות שאננות של צדיקים:[vi v]

Brief discourses,[1] limited in quantity yet profound in quality,[2] concerning the tranquil resting places of the righteous:[B]

[B]Or: "in the peaceful abodes of the righteous" — The Hebrew phrase could refer to spiritual 'abodes' rather than physical resting places, emphasizing the souls' dwelling rather than just their place of rest.

[1]The Hebrew term 'דרושים' (drushim) specifically refers to homiletical or exegetical teachings, often with mystical dimensions, rather than simply 'discourses' in the general sense.
[2]The Hebrew uses a play on words with 'קצרים בכמות ורבי האיכות' (literally 'short in quantity and great in quality'), creating a rhetorical contrast that is difficult to fully capture in translation.

[i]This metaphor likens the author to a faithful shepherdess delivering a message to her mighty one (Barzillai). The feminine 'shepherdess' (ro'iah tamah) may allude to the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) or Torah, suggesting the author sees his work as channeling divine wisdom rather than his own.
[ii]The closing blessing combines unusual metaphors ('your sneezes will shine light') with a biblical allusion to Proverbs 16:9. This reflects the author's belief that even involuntary actions (like sneezes) can have spiritual significance when one's thoughts are pure and aligned with divine will.
[iii]Cf. Tractate Semachot (Laws of Mourning) — The author is citing Tractate Semachot as a source for the materials he's adding to his work, showing that these additions are grounded in established rabbinic literature on death and mourning rituals. | Cf. Proverbs 16:9 — The author concludes with this reference to express his faith that despite his human efforts in composing this work, ultimately God directs the outcome and impact of his writings. | Cf. 2 Samuel 19:31-39 — The metaphor of 'delivering a word to her mighty one' (Barzillai) suggests the author sees himself as humbly offering wisdom to more powerful or established figures, perhaps the rabbinic authorities or his readers. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok itself — This passage reveals that what we're reading is a supplementary addition to Ma'avar Yabok that the author decided to include after the main book was already printed, containing material he had originally left out.
[iv]The author characterizes these teachings as brief in quantity but great in quality, a common rabbinic literary device expressing humility while also emphasizing the profound nature of the content to follow.
[v]This phrase refers to the peaceful spiritual realms where righteous souls dwell after death, corresponding to the concept of Gan Eden (Garden of Eden) in Jewish mystical thought. The image of 'tranquil resting places' contrasts with the upheaval of death, reinforcing Ma'avar Yabok's central message that death is a transition to peace rather than an ending.
[vi]Cf. Psalms 23:2 — This allusion frames the afterlife state of the righteous as a fulfillment of the divine promise in Psalms 23, where God leads the faithful to peaceful waters. In kabbalistic thought, these 'still waters' represent the higher spiritual realms where souls find perfect tranquility after death.

אשרי המחכה ויגיע להרגיע
בסוד נשמתו במקור מעין העליון
שהוא סוד בחינה אמצעית
שבמלת הנובעת לנוכח חותם
אמת דהיינו סוד עשר ספירות
כי שם הוא סוד מקום מנוחת
הצדיקים ויש להם שם בתוככיות
המלה שתי בחינות. האחד
גן והב׳ עדן. הגן הוא מקום
עמידתם והעדן הוא מקום שממנו
מתעדנות והיינו גן גל כי עקר
מיין נוקבין שהיא נובעת למעלה
הוא מעשה הצדיקים והיא
תכלית הנהגת א״ס בתחתונים
שהרי כל ההנהגה על ידה. והוא
עולה ממטה למעלה על ידי
היות קשר הנמצאים התחתונים
בשירם ובזמר׳ עולה עד א״ס.
וההקשר לעלות אל תכלית
העליה הנה תהיה משרשת
בעצמה כל המציאות והשיר
והעבודה התחתונה שכוונת כל
המשוררים והעובדים אליו והיא
אוספת הכל ועולה ממציאות
אל מציאות ומתאחדת במקומה
אוספת כל הנעשה והנוצר
והנברא ואוספת כל ו׳ קצוות
ומאחדם ועולה בבינה ואוספת
שם כח התעוררותיהם ועולה
אל החכמה ואוספת התעררותה
ועולה עד קשרה בכתר בא״ס ואז
היא עטרת בעלה מצד הכתר ואז
היא בסוד זרקא עד שהיא נקודה
מאחדת כל המציאות בדפי׳
והיא י׳ על וא״ו בסוד הדעת

Happy is the one who waits and reaches repose[1] in
the mystery of his soul at the source of the super- 60R
nal spring, which is the mystery of the middle as-
pect within the word that flows toward the seal of
truth,[2] namely the mystery of the ten sefirot. For
there is the mystery of the righteous ones' resting
place, and they have there, within the innermost 65R
parts of the word, two aspects. The first is the Gar-
den and the second is Eden. The Garden is the place
of their standing, and Eden is the place from which
they receive delight. This is the meaning of "Garden-
mound,"[3] for the essence of the feminine waters that 70R
flow upward is the deed of the righteous, and this is
the purpose of the Ein Sof's governance of the lower
realms, since all governance is through it. And it
ascends from below to above through the connec-
tion of the lower beings,[4] through their song and 75R
melody, rising up to the Ein Sof. And the connec-
tion to ascend to the ultimate height is rooted within
itself—all of existence, song, and the service of those
below, since the intention of all who sing and serve
is directed toward it. And it gathers everything and 80R
rises from one level of existence to another, unifying
in its place, gathering all that is made, formed, and
created, gathering all six extremities and unifying
them, and rising to Binah, gathering there the power
of their arousal, and rising to Chokhmah, gather- 85R
ing its arousal, and rising until it connects to Keter
within Ein Sof. Then it becomes the crown of its
husband from the aspect of Keter, and then it is in
the mystery of the Zarka, until it becomes a point
that unifies all existence as explained. And it is the 90R
Yod above the Vav in the mystery of Da'at[5] that
emerges from Chokhmah and rises above its dwelling
place, and no sefirah ascends there. The meaning of

[1]The opening phrase 'ashrei ha-mechakeh' echoes Daniel 12:12 ('Happy is the one who waits'), connecting this mystical teaching about the afterlife to biblical prophecies about ultimate redemption and resurrection.

[2]This densely mystical phrase refers to Malkhut (Kingdom), the tenth sefirah, positioned as a mediating aspect between higher divine realms and our material world. The 'seal of truth' refers to the divine name that confirms cosmic unity.

[3]The Hebrew 'gan gal' creates a wordplay that's difficult to translate precisely. 'Gal' means both 'mound' and 'reveal,' suggesting that the Garden of Eden is both a raised place and a place of revelation.

[4]This describes the kabbalistic principle that human spiritual practices (prayer, song, mitzvot) create actual ascension pathways for divine energy to circulate between worlds, affecting the cosmic balance between divine attributes.

[5]This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the shape of certain Hebrew letters represents cosmic structures. Here, the placement of Yod (י) above Vav (ו) symbolizes the connection between higher and lower spiritual realms through Da'at (Knowledge).

שיוצא מחכמה ועלתה למעלה
ממכון שבתו ואין שום ספירה
עולה שם ופי׳ זרקא שהיא נזרקת
ממטה למעלה עד א״ס ותכלית
ואחר כך היא יורדת מאירה
מאור א״ס ממה שהעלית מעבודת
התחתונים וסוד העלייה זאת
היא יחוד ק״ש וסוד כח שיר
המלאכים והכסא שסוד עבודתם
הוא היחוד הזה כי הזוג הוא חלק
לעם ה׳ ובבחינות אלו נק׳ ז״את
וזהו מי זאת עולה מן המדבר
כנדרש אלינו במקומו והמדבר
יהיה פירושו מקום הדבור והכל
תלוי בהתעוררות הצדיקים: [i]

Zarka is that it is cast from below to above, up to Ein Sof and the ultimate, and afterward it descends, illuminated by the light of Ein Sof, from what you elevated through the service of those below. And the mystery of this ascent is the unification of the Shema,[1] and the mystery of the power of the angels' song and the Throne, for the mystery of their service is this unification, because the union is a portion for the people of God. And in these aspects it is called "Zot" (This), and this is the meaning of "Who is this (zot) that rises from the wilderness," as expounded to us in its place, and "the wilderness" would be interpreted as the place of speech, and everything depends on the arousal of the righteous.[2]

פרק ב׳

בזה נבין למה זווג הנעשה בכל
מעשה בראשית לא היה פנים אל
פנים מצד שאין מעורר מלמטה
כדכתיב וכל עשב השדה וגו׳
משום ואדם אין. [ii] כי אם אדם
מעורר כלם פונים פניהם ממטה
למעלה והעילות פונות באור
ישר ממעלה למטה וזה כי סוד
אדם הוא אחרית הנמצאים ועד

Chapter 2

By this we understand why the union that occurred during the entire work of Creation was not face-to-face, because there was no awakening from below, as it is written: "And every plant of the field," etc., "because there was no man." For when man provides the awakening, all beings turn their faces upward, and the higher causes turn with direct light from above downward. This is because the mystery of Adam represents the final purpose of all created beings. Un-

[1] The Shema prayer ('Hear O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is One') is understood in Kabbalah as a powerful tool for unifying divine names and attributes across cosmic realms, affecting the soul's journey after death.

[2] The passage concludes by emphasizing that the entire cosmic system of ascent and divine unification depends on human initiative—specifically the 'arousal' or spiritual awakening created by righteous individuals through their actions and intentions.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 5, Chapter 1 — This passage establishes the theological framework for understanding the soul's journey after death, presenting the Garden of Eden as both a physical location and a mystical state where righteous souls experience spiritual delight through their connection to divine emanations. | Cf. Song of Songs 3:6 — The author reinterprets this biblical verse, replacing 'who' with 'what' to refer to the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) or the soul ascending through spiritual realms after being purified in the 'wilderness' of this world. This mystical reinterpretation is common in kabbalistic literature where biblical verses are given cosmic significance. | Cf. Zohar I:11b — The passage draws on the Zoharic concept that the Garden of Eden has both an upper and lower aspect, corresponding to different spiritual levels of the soul's experience after death. The distinction between 'Garden' and 'Eden' reflects the kabbalistic understanding that Eden is the source of divine pleasure while the Garden is where souls receive this pleasure. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Introduction — The passage incorporates the Tikkunei Zohar's concept of 'feminine waters' (mayin nukvin) representing spiritual initiatives from below that stimulate response from above. This cosmic dynamic is presented as the mechanism through which righteous souls affect higher spiritual realms.

[ii] This refers to Genesis 2:5, which states that plants had not yet sprouted because 'there was no man to work the ground.' In kabbalistic interpretation, this indicates the cosmic necessity of human consciousness to complete the divine creative process.

אדם היו כלם יורדין ומתפשטים
יורדין ומשתלשלי׳[i] והיאך יחזרו
בסוד אור ישר שעדין לא הגיע
המציאות ממעלה למטה אל
סוף קצהו. כיון שנמצא אדם
השלים והחתים סוף ההתפשטות
ופנה ממטה למעלה ועשה שכל
הנמצאים יתנו פניהם בסוד
אור חוזר ממטה למעלה וזהו
מציאות אדם שנמצא לעבוד
את האדמה לתקן ולקשט לה
פנים.[ii] ובזה תבין חטא א״ה
עם מה שארז״ל שאמר לכל
הנמצאים בואו נשתחוה ונכרעה
נברכה לפני ה׳ עושנו וזה
יהיה שכר הצדיקים כי יזכו
לקבל השפע והארה לנשמתם
בכח מעשיהם פנים אל פנים
מה שבתחלה היה אחור באחור
וזהו לדעתי סוד מאן דאכיל
דלאו דיליה בהיל לאסתכולי
ביה[iii] ודי למבין. ולהיות שעיקר
נביעת המ׳ למעלה הוא מעשה
הצדיקים שמכללת יופי מעשיהם
בסוד נקודת ציון שבה שהיא
בחינת עצמותה א״כ הצדיקים
נחים ויושבים בגן עדניה והיא
נוטלת התעוררותם. וע״י הגל
מעלה אותם למעלה ומיד המעין
נובע מלמטה למעלה ואז היא
מקבלת אור מלמעלה ונובע
ממעלה למטה והיינו גל נעול
מעין חתום[iv] כי בזה נעשית

til Adam's creation, everything was descending and expanding, descending and being drawn down in a chain—so how could they return in the manner of direct light when the process of manifestation from above to below had not yet reached its ultimate end?

Once Adam came into being, he completed and sealed the end of this expansion, and then turned from below upward, causing all created beings to turn their faces in the mode of reflected light from below upward. This is the very purpose of Adam's existence: "to work the ground"—to rectify and adorn the world with divine countenance. Through this you will understand Adam's sin, along with what our Sages taught, that he said to all creatures: "Come, let us bow down and kneel, let us bless before the Lord our Maker." And this will be the reward of the righteous: they will merit receiving divine flow and illumination for their souls through the power of their deeds, face-to-face, whereas initially it was back-to-back.[1] This, in my view, is the secret meaning of "one who eats what is not his is afraid to look at the giver"—and this is enough for the wise to understand.

Since the primary upward flow of Malkhut stems from the deeds of the righteous, as she incorporates the beauty of their actions within the point of Zion within her,[2] which is the essence of her being, the righteous rest and dwell in her Garden of Eden, and she takes up their awakening. Through the "mound" she elevates them upward, and immediately the spring flows from below upward. Then she receives light from above, which flows from above downward. This is the meaning of "a locked garden, a sealed

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of divine unification modes: 'back-to-back' (achor b'achor) represents distant or limited connection, while 'face-to-face' (panim b'panim) represents complete, intimate spiritual union.

[2] In Kabbalah, 'nekudat Tzion' (the point of Zion) refers to the innermost aspect of Malkhut where it connects to higher divine realms, particularly Yesod. This is the channel through which divine energy flows into our world.

[i] The term 'hishtalshelut' (chain/descent) is a key kabbalistic concept referring to the process by which divine energy progressively descends through various spiritual levels until reaching our physical world.

[ii] This phrase reinterprets Genesis 2:5 ('to till the ground') in kabbalistic terms as humanity's cosmic purpose: to 'adorn' or beautify creation by elevating it spiritually through proper intention and action.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase from the Talmud means 'one who eats what isn't his is afraid to look at the giver,' used here metaphorically to describe the spiritual discomfort of receiving divine blessing without deserving it through proper spiritual preparation.

[iv] This refers to Song of Songs 4:12 ('a garden locked, a fountain sealed'). In kabbalistic interpre-

מעין דהוא חתום לבל יכנסו
החצונים בכח בעלי תשובה
הכובשים את יצרם וזהו סוד
יגר שהדותא[i] למבינים וזה
יהיה כונת האדם לעורר עצמו
להכלל בסוד הזווג להיות כי
יש דיוקן אל הנשמה שם והוא
נכלל במציאות הרוחני העליון
שורש נשמתו ואז דיוקן ההוא
עולה שם בהתעוררות ההוא
ולזה צריך לכוין באומרו אליך
ה׳ נפשי אשא להכליל שם סוד
הדיוקן הזה לפעול הענין ההוא
שכל הדיוקנאות של נשמות הם
במלה ובאותן הדיוקנאות הם
נכללות הנשמות וזהו בידך
אפקיד רוחי[ii] והיחוד הנעשה
בלילה. וכ״ש בשעת מיתת
הצדיק נוסף מהנעשה ביום כי
ביום אינם אלא הדיוקנאות
ובלילה ובשעת מיתה יצטרפו
הדיוקנאות עם מציאותם בתוכם
כי יש שם עצם הנשמה ועד חצות
זיוג אל הבינה עם ת״ת ומאותו
התעוררות שוכב יעקב עם לאה
ועושה חברה עם רחל[iii] ומחצות
ואילך משלח הנשמות אל הגופים
כדי שיהיו עושים היחוד בדרך
אחר שיעסקו בתורה. הנה כי יש

spring,"[1] for through this she becomes a spring that is sealed so that external forces cannot enter, through the power of penitents who conquer their evil inclination. This is the secret of "Yegar Sahaduta" for those who understand. 45R

This should be a person's intention: to awaken himself to be included in the mystery of the union, for there exists an image of the soul there, and it is included in the higher spiritual reality that is the root of his soul. Then that image ascends there through this awakening. This is why one must focus when saying "Unto You, O Lord, I lift up my soul"—to include there the mystery of this image, to actualize this matter. For all the images of souls are within the "word," and within those images the souls themselves are included. This is the meaning of "Into Your hand I commit my spirit"[2]—the union that occurs at night. 50R 55R 60R

All the more so at the time of a righteous person's death, when there is an addition to what happens during the day. For during the day, only the images are present, but at night and at the time of death, the images combine with their actual essences within them, for the very essence of the soul is there. Until midnight there is a union of Binah with Tiferet, and from that awakening, Jacob lies with Leah and keeps company with Rachel.[3] From midnight onward, souls are sent to bodies[4] so that they may perform the union in another way—through Torah 65R 70R

[1] This reference to Song of Songs 4:12 is interpreted kabbalistically as describing how the Divine Feminine (Malkhut/Shekhinah) is protected from negative forces through the spiritual actions of the righteous and penitent.

[2] This verse (Psalm 31:6) is particularly significant in Ma'avar Yabok as it is recommended to be recited at the moment of death to facilitate the soul's peaceful transition.

[3] This metaphorical language describes cosmic unifications between divine attributes. In kabbalistic symbolism, Jacob represents Tiferet, Leah represents higher aspects of Malkhut, and Rachel represents lower aspects of Malkhut.

[4] This reflects the kabbalistic teaching that different spiritual processes occur before and after midnight. After midnight is considered an especially auspicious time for Torah study as new souls are being sent into the world.

tation, this represents how the Divine Feminine (Malkhut/Shekhinah) is protected from negative spiritual forces through the power of repentance and righteous deeds.

[i] This Aramaic phrase from Genesis 31:47 means 'heap of witness,' referring to the pile of stones marking the covenant between Jacob and Laban. Here it symbolizes the boundary separating holy and unholy realms maintained by penitents who master their inclinations.

[ii] This quote from Psalm 31:6 ('Into your hand I commit my spirit') is traditionally recited before sleep and at the time of death, serving as a surrender of the soul to divine protection during these vulnerable transitions.

[iii] In kabbalistic symbolism, Jacob represents Tiferet (central sefirah), while Leah and Rachel represent different aspects of Malkhut (Divine Feminine). This imagery describes cosmic unifications occurring at different times of night.

ג׳ יחודים בלילה כאשר בארנו במקום אחר:[i]

study. Thus there are three unions at night, as we have explained elsewhere.

פרק ג׳

Chapter 3

הצדיקים עולים בסוד נשמתם ונקשרים בסוד הבינה ונהנים שם בהשגחה בעולמות[ii] ותקוני השער שהוא בחינת דעת המתפשט בכל מקום ויופי רחמיהם ושלמותם שהגן להם בינה והעדן העליון שמתעדנים בו הוא מחכמה ומתקוני הכתר שהם מבחינה אחרונים שבכתר הנקרא מזל[iii] ועדן עילאה ועדן תתאה הם שתי חכמות וכן יסוד בעלותו אל הבינה יונק מהחכמה והכתר בבחינת שער רישא דא״א מפני שהוא מושרש שם ועל ידו הוא יניקת הצדיקים שזכו לנשמת האצילות מעולם הזכר והמצות הם למטה בזעיר

The righteous ascend through the mystery of their souls and bind themselves to the mystery of Binah[1] (Understanding), where they delight in the divine providence over worlds and in the rectifications of the "gate," which is the aspect of Da'at (Knowledge) that extends everywhere. They enjoy the beauty of their compassion and perfection, for Binah serves as their garden, while the supernal Eden in which they delight comes from Chokhmah (Wisdom) and from the configurations of Keter (Crown), specifically from the final aspects of Keter called "mazal" (divine influence).[2] The upper Eden and lower Eden are the two Wisdoms. Similarly, Yesod (Foundation), when it ascends to Binah, draws nourishment from Chokhmah and Keter through the aspect of the "hair of the head of Arich Anpin," because it is rooted there. Through

[1]The Hebrew term 'sod' (mystery) appears repeatedly in this passage and is a technical term in Kabbalah referring to the deepest metaphysical essence of something. The binding to Binah represents a spiritual unification with higher divine realms.

[2]In Lurianic Kabbalah, the lowest aspects of Keter manifest as the thirteen 'streams' or 'mazalot' that flow through the metaphorical beard of Arich Anpin, channeling divine abundance to lower realms.

[i]Cf. Genesis 2:5 — The passage cites Genesis 2:5 to establish that Creation was initially incomplete because there was no human to provide the 'awakening from below' that would establish proper spiritual circulation between upper and lower worlds. | Cf. Zohar — The concepts of 'or yashar' (direct light) and 'or chozer' (reflected light) are fundamental in Lurianic Kabbalah, describing how divine energy flows downward from God and then is reflected back upward through human spiritual activity. | Cf. Psalms 95:6 — The text attributes this psalm verse to Adam, suggesting he attempted to lead all creatures in worship, which connects to discussions about Adam's role as cosmic mediator. | Cf. Genesis 31:47 — This Aramaic phrase from the Torah meaning 'heap of witness' is used metaphorically here to represent the boundary that separates holy and unholy realms, maintained by the power of repentance. | Cf. Psalms 25:1 — This psalm verse is presented as a meditation focus for elevating one's soul-image to higher realms during prayer, part of the book's practical guidance for spiritual elevation. | Cf. Psalms 31:6 — This verse, recited before sleep and at death, is presented as creating a spiritual union between the soul and its divine source—a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to deathbed rituals. | Cf. Song of Songs 4:12 — This verse from Song of Songs is interpreted kabbalistically as referring to Malkhut (the Shekhinah/Divine Presence) being protected from external forces through the spiritual actions of the righteous. | Cf. Zohar III:244b — The text draws on Zoharic teachings about midnight as a time of divine unions, where Jacob (representing Tiferet) unites with Leah (higher aspects of Malkhut) before midnight and Rachel (lower aspects of Malkhut) after midnight.

[ii]The term 'hashgachah' (providence/supervision) in this context refers to the souls' ability to perceive divine governance over lower worlds, a privilege granted only to those who have ascended to higher spiritual realms.

[iii]The text refers here to the thirteen 'mazalot' or channels of divine influence that flow from the beard of Arich Anpin in Lurianic Kabbalah, which transmit divine abundance to lower realms.

במקום שיש ימין ושמאל עשה
ול״ת אמנם אור הכתר מאיר
בהם למטה והצדיקים ששמרו
המצות ותקנום למטה עוברים
ממנו ולמעלה.[i] והנה במצות
יכוין האדם למטה בימין ושמאל
לפי מציאותם אם עשה ואם לא
תעשה ובהארתם יכוין מלמעלה
בסוד המעין הנובעין בשערות
שממנו מאירים ואור הצדיקים
הוא מסוד האורח שהוא באמצע
רישא עילאה חיוורא. ועליו
נאמר ואורח צדיקים כאור
נוגה וגו׳ ומוצא האורח הזה מן
החכמה הנעלמה מוחא סתימא
דשקיט וענג שהם עדן נהר
גן לצדיקים הוא סוד האורח
הזה והם על ה׳ ודאי לעילא
מז״א. והצדיקים שיוכללו
בנשמתם הספירות העליונות
עולם הזכר אחר שיטהר העולם
ישיגו אור עליון מעין עליון
המאיר לעין תחתון והיינו עין
בעין יראו.[ii] אמנם לצדיקים
שהם בעולם הנקבה אפרוחים
או בצים לא ישיגו זה.[iii] וסוד
ג״ע היא בינה גן לחכמה שנקרא
עדן סוד הצדיקים שהם יסוד
יש להם נחת רוח בגן עדן ונחת
זה להם לעולם הבא ומתרין
נוקבין מבחינת חוטמא עילאה
דביה נשיבו רוחא דחיי יהיה
התעוררות תחית המתים:[iv]

this channel flows the spiritual nourishment of the righteous who have merited the soul of Atzilut (Emanation) from the masculine realm.[1]

The commandments exist below in Zeir Anpin, in the place where there is right and left, positive and negative commandments. However, the light of Keter shines upon them from above, and the righteous who have observed and perfected the commandments below pass through it and beyond. In performing the commandments, a person should direct their intention below to the right and left according to their nature—whether they are positive or negative commandments—while in their illumination, one should direct intention from above, through the mystery of the spring that flows through the "hairs" from which they shine forth.[2]

The light of the righteous comes from the mystery of the "path" that runs through the center of the supernal white head. Concerning this it is said, "The path of the righteous is like the light of dawn" (Proverbs 4:18). The source of this path is from the hidden wisdom, the concealed brain that is tranquil and delightful. These—Eden, River, and Garden for the righteous—are the mystery of this path, and they are certainly above Zeir Anpin.

The righteous whose souls will incorporate the supernal emanations of the masculine realm, after the world is purified, will attain the supernal light from the supernal spring that illuminates the lower eye, and thus "they shall see eye to eye" (Isaiah 52:8). However, the righteous who are in the feminine realm, like "chicks or eggs," will not attain this level.[3]

[1] This refers to souls whose spiritual root is in the highest of the four worlds (Atzilut/Emanation) and specifically in its masculine aspect, associated with the upper sefirot. Such souls have greater spiritual potential and achieve higher ascent after death.

[2] This is a reference to the kabbalistic concept where divine light flows through metaphorical 'hairs' (sa'arot), which are channels that restrict and direct divine abundance. The imagery represents how divine energy is precisely calibrated as it descends through cosmic structures.

[3] This metaphor compares less spiritually developed souls to undeveloped birds (chicks still in eggs

[i] This suggests a hierarchical spiritual ascent where the righteous who perfected commandments transcend even the illumination of Keter, reaching higher divine realms—a profound statement about the cosmic power of religious observance.

[ii] The biblical phrase 'eye to eye' is reinterpreted here to mean direct mystical perception without barriers, which will be possible only after cosmic rectification (tikkun) is complete.

[iii] The terms 'chicks or eggs' metaphorically describe souls at lower stages of spiritual development that belong to the 'feminine realm' (the lower sefirot), who cannot yet attain the highest levels of divine perception.

[iv] Cf. Zohar — This text draws heavily on Zoharic cosmology, especially the descriptions of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One), Zeir Anpin (the Small-Faced One), and the structure of the divine

The mystery of the Garden of Eden is that Binah is the garden for Chokhmah, which is called Eden. The mystery of the righteous, who correspond to Yesod, is that they find spiritual contentment in the Garden of Eden, and this contentment belongs to them in the World to Come. From the two nostrils of the supernal nose, through which blows the breath of life, will come the awakening of the resurrection of the dead. 55R

פרק ד׳

Chapter 4

עוד הורנו כי בחינת שערות דיקנא דאריך משתלשלים לארבע בחינות ראשונה שערות מספר ל״א בסוד שם אל שניה נימין כל שער ש״צ נימין. שלישית לכל שער ל״א עולמות. רביעית לכל עולם אלף עולמות כי שליטתם לכפות הדין וכלם הם להתעדן ולהשתעשע צדיקים ברבוי מיני העבודה אשר להם המבטלים הדינים במעשיהם והנה הקצוות מצד בחינת הת״ת והנימין מצד היסוד והנעלמות מצד המלכות שעולם הוא כללות ו׳ קצוות בכל מקום והיא בעצמה כלולה מאלף

He further taught us that the hairs of the beard of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One)[A] descend in four aspects: First, hairs numbering thirty-one, corresponding to the divine name El; second, strands—each hair containing 390 strands; third, each hair contains thirty-one worlds; fourth, each world contains one thousand worlds. For their dominion is to subdue judgment,[B] and all exist for the delight and pleasure of the righteous through the many forms of divine service by which they nullify judgments through their actions. 5R 10R

The extremities emanate from the aspect of Tiferet (Beauty), the strands from Yesod (Foundation), and the hidden aspects from Malchut (Kingdom). For "world" always encompasses the six extremities in every place, and Malchut itself 15R

[A] Or: "the beard of the Ancient One" — The term 'Arich Anpin' (Long-Faced One) could alternatively be translated as 'Ancient One,' which is another common way to render this kabbalistic concept referring to the highest configuration of divinity in Lurianic Kabbalah. Both translations accurately convey the mystical concept, though 'Ancient One' might be more accessible to readers less familiar with kabbalistic terminology.

[B] Or: "For their function is to sweeten the severity of judgment" — In Kabbalistic terminology, 'sweetening' (המתקת הדינים) is often used to describe the process of tempering or subduing harsh judgments. This alternate translation more precisely captures the technical mystical concept being described, where divine mercy transforms or mitigates the severity of judgment.

or newly hatched), contrasting them with fully mature souls. This reflects the kabbalistic hierarchy of souls and their varying capacities for divine perception after death.

worlds. The Zohar frequently discusses how the souls of the righteous ascend through various spiritual realms after death. | Cf. Proverbs 4:18 — This biblical verse is reinterpreted in a kabbalistic context to describe the spiritual illumination that righteous souls experience as they ascend through higher realms after death. | Cf. Isaiah 52:8 — This prophetic verse about the restoration of Zion is reinterpreted kabbalistically to describe the direct spiritual vision that elevated souls will attain in the highest realms. | Cf. Lurianic Kabbalah — This passage reflects post-Zoharic developments in Kabbalah, particularly from the Lurianic school, which elaborated on the concept of partzufim (divine 'faces' or configurations) as complete structures comprising multiple sefirot. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The structure of Eden, River, and Garden (representing Chokhmah, Da'at, and Binah) is a common motif in Tikkunei Zohar and related texts, symbolizing the flow of divine energy through the higher sefirot.

עולמות בה והיא משפעת ודנה
לעולמות שתחתיה כי התחתונים
אינם נדונים בגבורות בחינת
הזכר ח״ו שאין חצונים קרבים
שם אלא בגבורה תחתונה היא
המלכות שזה מדת הדין הרפה
שהם יכולים לסבלו ונעשה
ע״י החיצונים. והגבורה הקשה
דנה לעולמים הרוחניים שאינם
נדונים ע״י הכלים החצונים כלל
אלא ע״י נהר דינור ולכן הדינים
של הנשמה קשים יותר מדיני
הגוף ותשובה אחת בעוה״ז יפה
ומעולה מכמה מיתות וסיבובים.
לכן מעט שנות מעט תנומות
מעט חיבוק ידים לשכב בתענוגי
והבלי הזמן. פוק חזי מה שדרשו
בפ׳ השוכר את הפועלים. על
הפסוק תשת חשך ויהי לילה
זה העוה״ז וכו׳. עד יצא אדם
לפעלו בעוה״ז יצאו צדיקים
לקבל שכרן למי שהשלים
עבודתו עדי ערב ואור שהוא
יקר בעוה״ז יהוה קפוי לעוה״ב
כדדרשו בפ׳ אלו עוברין.
ותחלת מוצא ג״ע הנסתר ברום
חביון הוא כי הנקודה הנעלמה
שממנו התפשטות הכל והיא
יסוד כל ההתפשטות יקרא עדן
והתפשטות ההויות יקרא גן הנה
הגן נמשך מעדן ויהיה העדן
בינוי ליסוד הנמצאות והתחלת
מציאותם והעדן אינה מושגת
כלל. שממנה עדון הנמצאות
בהויות העצמים מעדן נקודת
הטפה הזרעית ולכן סוד העדן
תמיד קיים יסוד מוסד להויות
המציאות וכל עדן הוא מציאות
החכמה ראשית ההויות וממנו
עדון ההויות ונביעתם והגן

contains one thousand worlds within it. It influences and judges the worlds beneath it, for the lower realms are not judged by the severe powers of the masculine aspect, God forbid, as external forces cannot approach there. Rather, they are judged by the lower power—Malchut—which is the milder form of judgment that they can endure, administered through the external forces. 20R

The severe power of judgment governs the spiritual worlds, which are not judged through external instruments at all, but through the River of Fire.[A] Therefore, the judgments of the soul are more severe than those of the body, and a single act of repentance in this world is more beautiful and superior than many deaths and cycles of rebirth. So, "a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to lie in the pleasures and vanities of time."[B] 25R 30R

Go and see what they interpreted in the chapter "The One Who Hires Workers" on the verse "You bring darkness and it becomes night"—this refers to this world, etc. Until "man goes forth to his work" in this world, the righteous go forth to receive their reward—for one who completes his service by evening. And light, which is precious in this world, will be abundant in the World to Come, as they interpreted in the chapter "These Pass Over." 35R 40R

The beginning of the hidden Garden of Eden in the heights of concealment is the hidden point from which everything extends. It is the foundation of all extension, called Eden, while the extension of existences is called Garden. Thus, the Garden flows from Eden, and Eden is a term for the foundation of existences and the beginning of their reality. Eden itself cannot be grasped at all, for from it comes the delight of existences, like the essence of beings from Eden—the point of the seminal drop. Therefore, the mystery of Eden always exists as an established foundation for the existences of reality. 45R 50R

Every Eden is the reality of Wisdom, the beginning of existences, and from it comes the delight of 55R

[A] Or: "Nehar Dinur" — Keeping the original Aramaic term 'Nehar Dinur' might be preferable when discussing this specific mystical concept from Jewish tradition, as it appears in the Talmud and other rabbinic literature. However, the translation 'River of Fire' is more immediately comprehensible to readers unfamiliar with the original term.

[B] Or: "a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to rest—this refers to indulging in temporal pleasures and vanities" — This alternate translation makes clearer that the passage is adapting the biblical verse from Proverbs 6:10 (which warns against laziness) to make a different point about worldly indulgences. The expanded translation clarifies that this is an interpretive application of the biblical verse rather than a direct quotation.

היא סוד הבינה הנמשכת ממנו עד דאית גן עדן למעלה נסתר ברום חביון. ועל דא אמרי אית עדן ואית עדן. ומריש מילין אלה ישכיל המעין בסוד גן עדן מעולם הבריאה סוד הכסא וכן בג״ע תחתון ממנו אשרי עין רואה כל אלה: [i]

existences and their flowing forth. The Garden is the mystery of Understanding that extends from it, until there is a Garden of Eden above, hidden in the heights of concealment. And concerning this they say, "There is Eden and there is Eden." From these principles, the discerning one will gain insight into the mystery of the Garden of Eden from the World of Creation—the mystery of the Throne—and likewise into the lower Garden of Eden that derives from it. Happy is the eye that sees all these things.

פרק ה׳

Chapter 5

טעם הנהגת העולם בדין לקיום הנמצאים

The Reason for the Governance of the World Through Judgment for the Sustenance of Creation

אמרו מחצדי חקלא כי הוצרך מתחלה הנהגת הדין והנהגת הרחמים נפרדות דו פרצופין אחור באחור [ii] בדי שימצא הנהגה קשה ליסר החוטאים בדור המבול וביום החרבן וכיוצא והעבודה הרצויה לפניו מבני אדם הנכללים מיצר טוב

The reapers of the field explain[1] that initially, the attributes of Judgment and Mercy were required to function separately, as "two faces back-to-back," in order to enable strict governance to discipline sinners in the generation of the Flood, the day of the Temple's destruction, and similar occasions. The service pleasing to Him from humans—who are composed of both good and evil inclinations—is that

[1] The original Hebrew term 'מחצדי חקלא' (reapers of the field) is a technical term from the Zohar referring to mystical sages who gather and explain spiritual wisdom. I've translated it literally while noting its specialized meaning.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 3, Chapter 1 — This passage builds upon earlier explanations in Ma'avar Yabok about the soul's journey after death, adding details about the cosmic structure of divine realms where righteous souls dwell after death. The earlier section established the basic framework of the soul's components (nefesh, ruach, neshamah), while this section elaborates on the celestial environments these soul components encounter. | Cf. Zohar III:128b-129a — This passage draws heavily from the Zohar's detailed description of the 'beard of the Ancient One' (dikna d'atika), which represents channels of divine mercy flowing into creation. The author adapts this Zoharic concept to explain how divine mercy mitigates judgment in the afterlife realms, particularly for the righteous who have properly prepared through repentance in this world. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar, Tikkun 70 — The passage incorporates terminology and concepts from Tikkun 70 of the Tikkunei Zohar, particularly in its description of how the divine worlds are structured and interconnected. This reference helps establish the author's view of the afterlife as a complex multi-leveled reality rather than a simple binary heaven/hell model. | Cf. Proverbs 6:10 — The author repurposes this biblical verse, which originally warned against physical laziness, to instead caution against spiritual laziness and indulgence in worldly pleasures. This creative reinterpretation demonstrates the author's method of finding new spiritual meanings in traditional texts. | Cf. Genesis 2:8-10 — The passage offers a kabbalistic interpretation of the biblical Eden, transforming the physical garden of Genesis into a complex metaphysical structure representing divine wisdom (Eden) flowing into divine understanding (the Garden). This mystical reading aligns with traditional kabbalistic interpretations that view biblical narratives as encoding deeper metaphysical truths.

[ii] This describes the primordial cosmic state where the divine attributes of Judgment (Din) and Mercy (Rachamim) were initially positioned 'back-to-back' (achor be-achor), a fundamental concept in Lurianic Kabbalah representing separation and incomplete relationship before cosmic rectification.

ויצר הרע שע״י עבודתם ימזיגו
וימתיקו ב׳ הנהגות האלו ויתקנו
הספירות וההנהגות בהמזגת
הדין ברחמים. על בני אדם
המשרה לתקנם למתקם ליחדם
באופן שיהיה ה׳ הוא האלהים.
והאלהים הוא ה׳. עוד ראוי
להודיע כי לא היה אפשר לעולם
ולהויות התחתונים להמצא
בלי גבורה חזקה ונפלאת ועל
זה נאמר שאלמלא מוראה של
מלכות איש את רעהו חיים
בלעו[i] כי יחזרו אל נרתקן ואין
מעמידם במקומם בהתפשטות
והשתלשלות אלא מצד רוב הדין
הגובר עליהם ומעמידם על
עמדם והנה מטעם זה בהמתק
דינם מיד ההיכלות נותנים רשות
זה לזה כל אחד ואחד ליכנס
בתחומו של חבירו ויתעלו
ויבלעו זה בזה וכן בחות הכסא
אין מעמידם על משמרתם אלא
כח הדין החזק הנפלא ומכאן
תבין ותדע בכל הויות התחתונות
עד בני אדם כפשט המשנה איש
את רעהו חיים בלעו. א״כ עקר
ההנהגה הוא הדין והדין מוציא
כלי זעמו שמבלעדם אי אפשר
מפני שהאש החזק יעשה היתוך
ולזה הנהגת הדין צריכה מאד
מאד והשפעות הדינים מבינה
לאה וממ״ל רחל למטה במקום
העבד והשפחה נרמזים בתורה
בזלפה ובלהה. זלפה שפחת
לאה שהיא מזלפת בסוד העבד
שם השפעתה[ii] ואין החצוני
נאחז לה׳ ראשונה אלא על
ידי השפחה הזאת ויעקב פדאה

through their devotion they blend and sweeten these two modes of divine governance,[1] rectifying the sefirot and their operations by tempering Judgment with Mercy. This responsibility has been placed upon humanity: to perfect, sweeten, and unify these attributes so that "the LORD is God" and "God is the LORD." 15R

Furthermore, it is important to understand that the world and lower creations could not exist without a strong and wondrous power of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), as it is said, "If not for the fear of government, people would swallow each other alive." For without this, all would return to their original formless state. Nothing maintains them in their proper place and order of emanation except the abundance of Judgment prevailing over them and establishing them in their positions. 20R 25R

For this reason, when their judgment is sweetened, the celestial palaces immediately grant permission to one another, each entering the domain of its fellow, ascending and absorbing one another. Similarly, the powers of the divine Throne are maintained in their posts only by the remarkable power of strict Judgment. From this, you can understand all lower beings down to humans, as the plain meaning of the Mishnah states: "People would swallow each other alive." 30R 35R

Thus, the essence of governance is Judgment, and Judgment brings forth instruments of wrath[2] without which existence would be impossible, for intense fire would cause dissolution. Therefore, the governance of Judgment is absolutely necessary. The influences of judgment flow from Binah to Leah, and from the Mem-Lamed (initials of Malkhut) to Rachel below, in the place of the servant and handmaid, symbolized in Torah by Zilpah and Bilhah. 40R 45R

Zilpah, Leah's handmaid, distributes her influence in the mystery of the servant, and external

[1] The Hebrew terms 'הנהגת הדין' and 'הנהגת הרחמים' refer to how God governs the world through the seemingly opposite attributes of strict justice and compassionate mercy, a fundamental concept in Jewish mysticism.

[2] The phrase 'כלי זעמו' literally means 'vessels/instruments of His wrath' and refers to the cosmic mechanisms through which divine judgment manifests in the world.

[i] This quotes a famous Mishnaic teaching (Avot 3:2) about the necessity of government and social order, applying it to cosmic metaphysics—divine judgment functions like government, creating necessary boundaries that prevent chaos.

[ii] The text employs a wordplay with the name Zilpah (זלפה) and the verb 'mezalephet' (מזלפת), meaning to sprinkle or distribute, suggesting her name reflects her cosmic function of distributing divine influence to lower realms.

מיד לבן והשפיעה לנפרדים
50 בכשרות וטהרה לבן מוציאה
תקון בשבטים בפרקים היוצאים
חוץ בטהרה כדפירשו בזהר פ׳
ויצא ובלהה היא מקום שרחל
מתלבשת בה בהיותה יורדת
55 למטה ובלהה שמה מורה מקום
הדינים והיא שפחה כשרה אמנם
החצוני יונק משם ונפדית על
ידי סלוק רחל וכן פי׳ זלפה
קטנה בלהה גדולה[i] שסוד אחיזת
60 החצונים ברחל מרובה מאחיזתם
בלאה כנודע. הנה כי מלכותו
בכל משלה. גם כן המלאכים
ששלח יעקב היו מאותם שהם חוץ
להיכלות והם בעשיה ראשים על
65 הקליפות והם לבוש לד׳ מחנות
שכינה ועל כל זה אין קדש
וחול מתערבים ח״ו כ״ש טומאה
וטהרה וזהו סוד ההבדלות. הנה
הכרת ההנהגה הנזכר בזולת
70 כמה עניינים המתחייבים בזה
יצר טוב ויצר הרע וג״ע וגהינם
ושכר ועונש ומצות ועבירות
וטהור ומותר וטמא ואסור
והרבה:[ii]

forces cannot grasp the first Hei (of the divine name) except through this handmaid. Jacob redeemed her from Laban and channeled her influence to the separate beings in purity and holiness. Therefore, she brings forth rectification through the tribes in the "outer limbs" in purity,[1] as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Vayetzei. 50R 55R

Bilhah is the place where Rachel clothes herself when descending below. Her name indicates the place of judgments, and though she is a kosher handmaid, external forces draw sustenance from there, which is redeemed through Rachel's withdrawal. Thus, Zilpah is considered "small" while Bilhah is "great," for the external forces have a greater hold on Rachel than on Leah, as is known. 60R

Indeed, "His kingship rules over all." Even the angels sent by Jacob were from those outside the palaces, belonging to the World of Action (Asiyah), heads over the kelipot (shells/husks), serving as garments for the four camps of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). Despite all this, the holy and the mundane never mix, heaven forbid—how much more so purity and impurity—and this is the mystery of the separations. 65R 70R

The recognition of this governance necessarily entails many consequential matters: the good and evil inclinations, the Garden of Eden and Gehenna, reward and punishment, commandments and transgressions, the pure and the permitted, the impure and the forbidden, and much more. 75R

פרק ו׳

Chapter 6

טעם וסדר וכוונה איך יעוררו

The Meaning, Order, and Intention: How Those Be-

[1] The Hebrew phrase 'בפרקים היוצאים חוץ בטהרה' refers to spiritual channels that extend outward while maintaining their purity, a concept explained in the Zohar portion mentioned.

[i] This suggests a hierarchical relationship between the handmaids, with Bilhah being 'greater' than Zilpah because external forces have a stronger hold on Rachel (associated with Bilhah) than on Leah (associated with Zilpah), reflecting a mystical interpretation of Genesis 30.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayetzei — This reference supports the text's explanation of how Zilpah represents a specific channel of divine influence that operates through 'outer limbs' or peripheral aspects of the divine structure while maintaining purity. | Cf. Mishnah Avot 3:2 — The text uses this Mishnaic teaching to explain the cosmic necessity of judgment and limitation, drawing a parallel between human governance and divine judgment as forces that maintain order. | Cf. 1 Kings 18:39 — The text references this biblical declaration to illustrate the ultimate goal of human spiritual work: to reveal the unity of God's attributes of mercy and judgment, showing that they are ultimately one despite appearing separate. | Cf. Lurianic Kabbalah — The text draws on the Lurianic concept of 'achor be-achor' (back-to-back) positioning of divine countenances to explain how judgment and mercy initially functioned as separate forces before human spiritual work began to harmonize them.

התחתונים למעלה בתפלתן:

בעת הזווג צריך תקון הדינים מלמעלה והגבורות העליונות מתתקנות ומתמתקות וחמ׳ גם היא מלמטה מתתקנת ומטהרת והצדיקים בתפלתם ותשובתם ומעשים הטובים עוזרים מיד מסתלקים הדינים ממנה ועולה ומסתלקת[i] והעליה תהא על ידי כמה בחינות. הא׳ נכנסת לפנים משערי צדק שהם נצח הוד. הב׳ חבוקה בין תרין דרועין דמלכא וזה נקרא אהבה. הג׳ היותה מכוונת בבחינת אברים באברים עם כח המשפיע לה בחינת פניו על פניה בחינת ראש בראש בחינת גוף בגוף בחינת יד על יד הד׳ בחינות הנשיקות שהוא דבקות רוח החיים הפנימי מזו לזו ומזה לזה פי׳ ממקבל למשפיע והכל דוגמא להוית הכוחות המתאחים יחד להאיר. הה׳ כניסת היסוד אליה שהוא בסוד היחוד[ii] וזהו עיקר המתקת הדינים. הו׳ מזרעת הטפה העליונה והם ב׳ טפות טפת הזכר וטפת הנקבה ויש כאן סוד איש מזריע תחילה. הז׳ העבור: הח׳ הלידה. הט׳ חבלי לידה. הי׳ גדול ולדות. ואלו הבחינות כלם הארות עליונות[iii] ותקונים עליונות מהספירות עליונות אליה שדרך כלל אנו מכנים

low Awaken Those Above Through Their Prayer:

At the time of union, the judgments must be rectified from above, and the supernal powers of Gevurah become rectified and sweetened. Similarly, Malkhut 5R
below becomes rectified and purified. Through the prayers, repentance, and good deeds of the righteous, the judgments are immediately removed from her, and she ascends and elevates. This ascent occurs through several aspects: 10R

First, she enters within the gates of righteousness, which are Netzach and Hod.[1]

Second, she is embraced between the two arms of the King, and this is called love.

Third, she is aligned in the aspect of limb to limb 15R
with the power that flows to her—His face upon her face, head to head, body to body, hand upon hand.

Fourth, the aspect of kisses, which is the cleaving of the inner life-force from one to the other and back
again—that is, from receiver to giver—all this being 20R
a model for how spiritual forces unite to illuminate.

Fifth, the entry of Yesod into her, which is the secret of unification, and this is the essential sweetening of judgments.

Sixth, the emission of the supernal drop, which 25R
comprises two drops—the male drop and the female drop—and here lies the secret of "the man emits seed first."[2]

Seventh, pregnancy.

Eighth, birth. 30R

Ninth, birth pangs.

Tenth, the growth of offspring.

All these aspects are supernal illuminations and rectifications from the higher Sefirot flowing to her.

[1] The Hebrew uses the kabbalistic terminology 'Netzach' and 'Hod,' which refer to the seventh and eighth divine attributes in the sefirotic system. They are often depicted as the two lower 'pillars' or 'legs' of the divine structure, forming a gateway through which divine energy flows to Malkhut.

[2] This references a Talmudic concept (from Berakhot 60a) about gender determination, but in this kabbalistic context, it takes on a mystical meaning about the order of divine influences in cosmic unification.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept where divine judgments (dinim) are 'lifted' from the Shekhinah (Divine Presence) through proper prayer and ritual. This elevation allows the divine feminine aspect to ascend and unite with higher divine attributes.

[ii] In Kabbalah, Yesod (Foundation) is the divine attribute that channels the flow from all higher sefirot to Malkhut. This 'entry of Yesod' refers to the mystical unification of masculine and feminine divine aspects, which is considered the primary mechanism for 'sweetening judgments.'

[iii] The text presents a complex process of divine unification with ten distinct stages, mirroring both human procreation and the structure of the ten sefirot (divine emanations). These stages form a complete sequence from initial attraction to the development of new spiritual realities.

בעלה ספירות עליונות וכלם
משתוות בת״ת שבו עקר יחודה
ודרך כלל הם אליה ד׳ עניינים
טהרה קדושה ברכה יחוד.
ונכללים אלו בתפלות ויחודים
וכוונת המצות. ויש למ׳ שלשה
פנים למעלה שבהם מתיחדת עם
בעלה. הפן הא׳ יחודה בימין
והיינו בחסד שם אל והיא מגלה
פנים אליו בשם אל כגון בפסח
שמעורר שם אל חסד מלמעלה
כן גם היא מגלה פנים אליו
בסוד פניאל שבה. וכן בתפלת
שחרית. ובסוכות פנים המנהגים
הם אלהים סוד הגבורה גם היא
מגלה פנים בסוד שם אלהים שבה
לכן צריך הכנת תשובה תחלה
להמתיק הדין ולכן אז הוא זמן
שמחה בסוד יין המשמח וגדול
כח רגל זה שאפי׳ בחינת הדין
נמתק ומתלבן ובשבועות שתהיה
ההנהגה מצד קו האמצעי סוד
יחוד השלם היא מגלה פנים אליו
בשם אדנ״י ששם זה הוא מכוון
נגד שם הויה[i] וזה אל אלהים
ה׳ דבר ויקרא ארץ. ויש לה פן
רביעי נגד מטה כי ראוי לה ד׳
פנים נגד ד׳ הנהגות שהם סוד
הויה: [ii]

Generally, we refer to these higher Sefirot as her husband, and they all converge in Tiferet, which is the core of her unification. Overall, they provide her with four elements: purity, holiness, blessing, and unification. These are included in prayers, unifications, and the intentions of the commandments.

Malkhut has three faces above through which she unites with her husband. The first face is her unification with the right, namely with Chesed, the divine name El. She reveals her countenance to Him through the name El, as in Passover, which awakens the name El—Chesed from above—and she too reveals her countenance to Him through the secret of Peniel within her.[1] Similarly, in the morning prayer.

In Sukkot, the governing faces are Elohim, the secret of Gevurah. She also reveals her countenance through the secret of the name Elohim within her. Therefore, preparatory repentance is needed first to sweeten the judgment, which is why this is a time of joy through the secret of wine that gladdens. Great is the power of this festival, for even the aspect of judgment is sweetened and whitened.

In Shavuot, when governance comes from the central column, the secret of complete unification, she reveals her countenance to Him through the name Adonai, which corresponds directly to the name YHVH. This is "El Elohim YHVH spoke and called to earth."[2]

She has a fourth face directed downward, for she properly has four faces corresponding to the four

[1] Peniel (literally 'face of God') references Jacob's encounter with the divine in Genesis 32:31. In this kabbalistic context, it refers to how the divine feminine (Malkhut) reflects the divine attribute of mercy (El) during Passover.

[2] This is a quotation from Psalm 50:1, used here to illustrate how different divine names work together during Shavuot, representing the perfect balance and harmony of divine attributes during this festival.

[i] The divine names Adonai and YHVH are seen as complementary, representing the feminine and masculine aspects of divinity. Their proper alignment is considered essential for cosmic harmony, particularly during Shavuot which celebrates the giving of Torah and represents perfect divine balance.

[ii] Cf. Zohar II:135b — This passage elaborates on the Zoharic concept of divine unification (zivug), explaining how judgments are sweetened when Malkhut rises to unite with the higher divine attributes, particularly through the efforts of the righteous. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 4 — This passage connects to the book's broader theme that human prayers and righteous actions create cosmic effects, particularly the transformation of divine judgment into mercy. | Cf. Ezekiel 1:10 — The four faces of Malkhut allude to Ezekiel's vision of the four-faced creatures, suggesting that the Divine Feminine reflects the complete divine structure described in prophetic vision. | Cf. Tikunei Zohar, Tikun 21 — This reference provides a parallel explanation of how the Shekhinah/Malkhut manifests different aspects according to which divine attribute she is uniting with, similar to how the passage describes her having different 'faces' during different festivals.

modes of governance, which are the secret of the divine name YHVH. 65R

פרק ז׳

הפן הרביעי שאמרנו הפונה למטה ירצה מתפשט בתחתונים ופניו למטה שבו היא מקבלת מעשה התחתונים וכל השיר והשבח והתפלה והתורה ומעשה הטוב הנעשה למטה מבשלת אותו ועושה מטעמים לסוד התעוררות עליון.[i] ושואלת בשביל המלאכים בהתעוררות שירם וזמרם ושואלת לנמצאות התחתונות בשביל שבח העולה אליו מכל הנבראים דכתיב הללו את ה׳ מן השמים תנינים וכל תהומות אש וברד וגו׳[ii] הכל מלאכים ממונים בעולם העשיה ובשירת הצדיקים נכללים כל השירים כלם באשר הוכחנו מאמר א׳ פרק ל׳ ואפי׳ ברכה אחת או מצוה אחת או מעשה או דבור טוב הכל מתקבץ בסוד בזק בהיכל לבנת הספיר[iii] ועומד שם עד זמן עלייתה והכל מסודר בה. והיינו מיין נוקבין התעוררות התחתונים דאושידת לקבלא מיין דכורין[iv] השפע עליון והתעוררות זה עולה מבחינה אל בחינה היא אוספת אותו שם בסוד תקוניה ונובעת מסוד אבריה אל

Chapter 7

The fourth aspect that we mentioned, which faces downward,[1] refers to that which extends into the lower realms with its face turned downward. Through this aspect, she receives the deeds of those below, and all the song, praise, prayer, Torah study, 5R and good actions performed below—she processes them and transforms them into delicacies to awaken a response from above. She petitions on behalf of the angels through the arousal of their song and melody, and she petitions on behalf of the lower 10R creations through the praise that ascends to Him from all created beings, as it is written: "Praise the LORD from the heavens, sea monsters and all depths, fire and hail, etc." All these are angels appointed in the World of Action (Asiyah), and in 15R the song of the righteous, all songs are included, as we have proven in Discourse One, Chapter 30. Even a single blessing, a single commandment, or a good deed or word[2]—all are gathered with lightning speed in the Palace of the Sapphire Brick and remain there 20R until the time of her ascent, all arranged within her.

This constitutes the "feminine waters"—the arousal from below that she pours forth to receive the "masculine waters" of divine influx from above. This arousal ascends from one level to another; she 25R gathers it through her rectifications and causes it to flow from her limbs to the central point of beauty in order to awaken it. This arousal ascends whether it

[1] The original text uses the term 'הפן הרביעי' (the fourth aspect/face) as part of a discussion about the four aspects of Malkhut (the Divine Feminine), corresponding to the four directions or the four letters of God's name.

[2] This passage emphasizes the cosmic significance of even minor human religious actions, suggesting that every positive deed, no matter how small, contributes to the process of cosmic rectification and divine unification.

[i] This metaphor draws on Genesis 27:4 where Isaac asks Esau to prepare 'delicacies' (mat'amim). Here it refers to how human prayers and good deeds are transformed into spiritual sustenance that 'nourishes' and awakens divine response.

[ii] This reference to Psalm 148 is interpreted mystically, with natural phenomena understood as angelic forces appointed over different aspects of creation in the physical world (Asiyah).

[iii] The term 'בזק' (bezek) means 'lightning' or 'flash' and indicates the instantaneous collection of prayers and good deeds in the celestial Palace of the Sapphire Brick, a mystical chamber mentioned in Heikhalot literature and the Zohar.

[iv] These kabbalistic terms describe the reciprocal relationship between human spiritual activity (feminine waters rising from below) and divine response (masculine waters flowing from above), using sexual metaphors to explain cosmic processes.

סוד הנקודה אמצעית היופי הזה
30 כדי להתעוררה. והתעוררות
הזה תעלה בין שתהיה להזדווג
בין שתהיה להשפיע לה שפע
סתם ואלו הם הקדמות ריש
מלין ליודע שותא דרבנן והמלך
35 החכם אשר ישב על כסא ה׳
יסד ותקן מגלת שיר השירים בה
יחוד שכינה וגעגועיה ותיקוניה
וקשוטיה והגבר ראה עני בשבט
עברתו ירמיהו שהיה מלך
40 הכוש״י[i] שב ותקן מגלת איכה
הפכה ומשם ידרוש המעיין בכל
יכלתו ומגילת רות היא המ׳
שרותה להקב״ה בשיריה ובועז
צדיק יחודה והוא רודף אחר
45 היחוד אחריה והיא אחריו גם
כן ושם נעמי היא הבינה בסוד
לחזות בנועם ה׳ והיא המיעצת
אותה אל היחוד ביסוד אחי ת״ת
שהוא דרך היבום לא יחוד גמור
50 כמו ביום השבת[ii] ובועז הוא
מטט׳ עם נערותיו שבע נערות
יחוד ימי החול והוא זורה את
גורן השעורים כי הוא משליך
תבן וקש ומבער החצונים בסוד
55 שערה[iii] והיא בסוד פשתתי את
כתנתי שהיא התבן והקש והמוץ
המכסה על השערה וגם את תכין
עצמך אליו וזהו ורחצת וסכת

is for the purpose of unification or simply to bestow influx upon her. These are foundational principles, the beginning of words for one who understands the discourse of the sages. 30R

The wise king who sat on the throne of the LORD[1] established and arranged the scroll of the Song of Songs, which contains the unification of the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), her longings, her rectifications, and her adornments. And the man who "saw affliction by the rod of His wrath," Jeremiah, who was the Cushite king,[2] returned and composed the scroll of Lamentations, its opposite—from there the student may investigate with all his ability. 35R 40R

The scroll of Ruth represents Malkhut (Kingdom), who is connected to the Holy One, blessed be He, through her songs. Boaz represents the righteous one of her unification, who pursues unification after her, while she likewise pursues him. There, Naomi represents Binah (Understanding) in the mystery of "beholding the pleasantness of the LORD," and she is the one who counsels her toward unification with Yesod (Foundation), the brother of Tiferet (Beauty). This is the path of levirate marriage, not complete unification as on the Sabbath day.[3] Boaz is Metatron with his maidens, the seven maidens representing the unification of the weekdays.[4] He winnows the barley threshing floor, for he casts away straw and chaff, burning the external forces through the mystery of barley[5] (se'orah), while she 45R 50R 55R

[1] This refers to King Solomon, traditionally considered the author of Song of Songs. The description of him sitting 'on the throne of the LORD' comes from 1 Chronicles 29:23.

[2] The identification of Jeremiah as 'מלך הכוש״י' (the Cushite king) is unusual and likely draws on rabbinic interpretations connecting Jeremiah with the Cushite mentioned in Jeremiah 38:7-13.

[3] The text establishes a hierarchy of unifications, with weekday unions compared to levirate marriage (a duty-bound union) while Sabbath enables a higher, more complete divine union. This reflects the kabbalistic view that Sabbath creates the most favorable conditions for cosmic harmony.

[4] This refers to the seven days of the week, each associated with a different divine attribute (sefirah) and level of unification between masculine and feminine divine aspects.

[5] There is wordplay in the original between 'se'orah' (barley) and related terms that create mystical connections to concepts of divine judgment and purification of negative forces.

[i] The identification of Jeremiah as 'the Cushite king' is based on rabbinic interpretation of Jeremiah 38:7-13, where Ebed-melech the Cushite rescues Jeremiah. Some traditions identified Jeremiah himself as a Cushite, perhaps based on Numbers 12:1.

[ii] This distinguishes between two levels of divine unification: levirate marriage (yibbum) represents a lesser form of cosmic union available during weekdays, while Sabbath enables 'complete unification' (yichud gamur), a higher level of divine harmony.

[iii] There is wordplay here between 'se'orah' (barley) and 'sa'arah' (storm/tempest), as well as between 'se'orah' and 'se'ar' (hair). These phonetic connections create mystical links between the concepts of barley, divine judgment (storm), and channels of divine influence (hair).

ושמת שמלותיך עליך הם ד׳
60 תקונים בידוע להכנת הזווג
ורחצת וסכת הם תקונים מהבינה
והחכמה. ושמלות באים לה
מהכתר על ידי סוד י״ג מקורות
תקוני דיקנא עילאה ובאים
65 לתשע תקוני דיקנא דזעיר ומשם
על ידי הת״ת אליה. [i]

is in the mystery of "I have taken off my garment," which refers to the straw, chaff, and husk that cover the barley. 60R

"And you shall prepare yourself for him"—this is the meaning of "wash yourself, anoint yourself, and put your garments on"—these are the four rectifications, as is known, for preparing for unification. 65R "Wash yourself and anoint yourself" are rectifications from Binah and Chokhmah (Understanding and Wisdom). And garments come to her from Keter (Crown) through the mystery of the thirteen sources of the rectifications of the supernal beard, which flow 70R to the nine rectifications of the beard of Zeir Anpin, and from there through Tiferet to her.

פרק ח׳

Chapter 8

פסוקי היחוד ופירוש ה׳ אחד
ושמו אחד:

The Verses of Unification and the Explanation of "The LORD is One and His Name is One":

הטביע הבורא שתקון העליונים
תלוי בתחתונים ובזה אין
5 מתפרדין העליונים מן התחתונים
כדכתיב וירכב על כרוב ויעף
תחלה רוכבות הספירות על
המלכות לתקנה ואחר כך וידא
על בנפי רוח ובפסוק ישקני
10 מנשיקות פיהו [ii] כי טובים דודיך
מיין וכן וישק יעקב לרחל
וישא את קולו ויבך בהם שבעה

The Creator established that the rectification of the upper realms depends on the lower realms, and through this the upper and lower realms are not 5R separated from each other, as it is written, "And He rode upon a cherub, and did fly." First, the sefirot ride upon Malkhut to rectify it, and afterward, "He soared upon the wings of the wind." And in the verse, "Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, 10R for your love is better than wine," and likewise, "And Jacob kissed Rachel, and lifted up his voice,

[i] Cf. Song of Songs — The author presents Song of Songs as a mystical text about the relationship between God (represented by Solomon/Boaz) and the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). This allegorical reading of the biblical love poetry was standard in kabbalistic literature, where the text was seen as the most sacred depiction of divine unification. | Cf. Book of Ruth — The text presents Ruth as an allegory for Malkhut (the lowest sefirah, representing the Divine Feminine), with Boaz representing Yesod (Foundation) or a righteous intermediary like Metatron. Naomi is interpreted as Binah (Understanding), a higher feminine divine attribute that guides Malkhut toward proper unification. | Cf. Book of Lamentations — Lamentations is presented as the opposite of Song of Songs, composed by Jeremiah (described as 'the Cushite king') to represent the state of divine separation or exile, in contrast to the unification depicted in Song of Songs. | Cf. Psalm 148:7 — The citation 'Praise the LORD from the heavens, sea monsters and all depths, fire and hail' comes from Psalm 148, which the author interprets mystically as describing how all creation, through angelic intermediaries, offers praise that ascends to the Divine. | Cf. Palace of the Sapphire Brick — This refers to Heikhal Livnat HaSapir, one of the mystical palaces or chambers described in Heikhalot literature and the Zohar. It represents a celestial gathering place where prayers and good deeds are collected before being elevated to higher divine realms. | Cf. feminine waters (mayin nukvin) and masculine waters (mayin dekhurin) — These kabbalistic terms describe the reciprocal relationship between human spiritual activity (feminine waters rising from below) and divine response (masculine waters flowing from above). This sexual metaphor is central to kabbalistic understanding of how prayer and ritual stimulate cosmic unification.

[ii] This verse from Song of Songs 1:2 is interpreted mystically as describing the union between the divine masculine and feminine aspects, a foundational concept in Kabbalah.

תיבות לרמוז אל שבעה נשיקות
ז׳ הבלים[i] שמתדבק דכורא
בנוקבא ונוקבא בדכורא רוחא
ברוחא בסוד אהבה והם סוד
שבעה ושבעה מוצקות וירכב על
כרוב ויעף וגו׳ ישקני מנשיקות
פיהו וגו׳ אל אלהים ה׳ וגו׳
מציון מכלל יופי וגו׳ שמע
ישראל וגו׳ ה׳ הוא האלהים
ה׳ אחד ושמו אחד.[ii] ה׳ מלך
ה׳ מלך הבאים מלב שבו אל
לב שבה ועשר מאמרות שהם
בחכמה כדמות רוח החיים
עליהם והם ל״ב נתיבות[iii] שהם
סוד כללות ח׳ ספירות מבינה
ולמטה בארבעה ראשי ההנהגה
כלול כל אחד מהשמנה והם
סוד מ״ב בהשפעת אמש עליהם
שהם כתר חכמה בינה נשמה לז׳
הבלים. כלל היחודים הוא ה׳
אחד ושמו אחד הוא ושמו אחד
כי סוד רמ״ח אברים נרמזים
בסוד רמ״ח כתות קדושים שבשם
אדנ״י.[iv] היחוד צריך קשור
רמ״ח כתות קדושים שהם בעצמן
מעצמן אל עצמן והיינו ה׳ אחד
שיקשור סוד אותיות יה״וה י׳
בה׳ ו׳ בה׳ ויתיחד ה׳ אחד
ואח״כ שמו אחד רמ״ח כתות
קדושים שבשם אדנ״י ואח״כ
יתקשרו ב׳ שמות יחד הוא ושמו
אחד והכל על ידי תוספת הארה
שיש בזכר בסוד האבר הקדוש
הכי נקרא יוסף שממלא חסרון
הנקבה שהוא סוד י״ו נוספים
בזכר יו״ד בסוד טהרה על הו״או
ובזה יאיר בה וישלים דיניה.
סוד יחוד שמע ישראל יש לקשר

and wept”—in these are seven words, alluding to the seven kisses, the seven breaths through which the masculine cleaves to the feminine and the feminine to the masculine, spirit to spirit, in the mystery of love. These are the secret of “seven and seven spouts”: “And He rode upon a cherub, and did fly”; “Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth”; “God, the Lord God”; “From Zion, the perfection of beauty”; “Hear, O Israel”; “The Lord is God”; “The Lord is One and His Name is One.” The Lord reigns, the Lord has reigned—these come from the heart within Him to the heart within Her. The ten utterances, which are in Wisdom, are like the breath of life upon them, and they are the thirty-two paths, which are the mystery of the totality of the eight sefirot from Binah downward, with each of the eight included in the four primary modes of divine governance. They are the mystery of the forty-two, with the influence of AMS”H upon them, which are Keter, Chokhmah, and Binah, serving as the soul to the seven breaths. 15R 20R 25R 30R

The essence of all unifications is “The Lord is One and His Name is One”—He and His Name are One. For the mystery of the 248 limbs is alluded to in the mystery of the 248 holy assemblies contained within the divine name ADNY. Unification requires binding together the 248 holy assemblies that are inherently of themselves and to themselves. This is the meaning of “The Lord is One”—that one should bind together the mystery of the letters of YHVH: Yod with Hei, Vav with Hei, thus unifying “The Lord is One.” Afterward, “His Name is One” refers to the 248 holy assemblies within the name ADNY. Then the two names are bound together: “He and His Name are One.” All this is accomplished through the additional illumination present in the masculine aspect, through the mystery of the sacred organ. This is why Joseph is so called, because he fills the deficiency of 35R 40R 45R 50R

[i] The ‘seven breaths’ refer to the seven lower sefirot (from Chesed to Malkhut) that serve as channels for divine energy. The term ‘hevel’ (breath/vapor) connects to Ecclesiastes’ ‘vanities’ but is reinterpreted positively in Kabbalah as divine emanations.

[ii] This phrase from Zechariah 14:9 is central to Jewish eschatology and mysticism, representing the ultimate unification of all divine aspects at the end of days, which mystical practice seeks to manifest in the present.

[iii] The 32 paths of wisdom come from Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), an early mystical text, representing the 10 sefirot plus the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet that together form the building blocks of creation.

[iv] The number 248 (RaMaCH) is significant in Jewish mysticism as the number of positive commandments and the traditional count of limbs in the human body. Here it represents the complete structure of divine manifestation through the name ADNY.

א״ס בספירות ואחר כך לכוללם
על ידי היסוד במ׳ ומכחם פירות
העץ שהם פעולות הנק׳ פרי
העץ ופרי האדמה שהם פעילות
עצמה בכח המאציל העליון
ובחינת הזכר נכללות בו׳ תיבות
של שמע וכנגדם הוציאה למטה
בעולם הנקבה ששה מדרגות שהם
הכלל מציאות הנכללות בברוך
שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד
ובכל כוונתו לא יצייר בדעתו רק
אותיות משמות הקדש כפי העת
והמקום כי זה לבד הותר:[i] [ii]

the feminine, which is the mystery of the additional Yod-Vav in the masculine—Yod in the mystery of purity upon the Vav—thereby illuminating her and completing her judgments.

The secret of the unification in "Hear, O Israel" is to connect the Infinite (Ein Sof) with the sefirot, and afterward to include them through Yesod in Malkhut. From their power come the fruits of the tree, which are the actions called "fruit of the tree" and "fruit of the earth"—these are its own activities empowered by the Supernal Emanator. The masculine aspect is included in the six words of the Shema, and corresponding to them, She brought forth below, in the feminine world, six levels, which are the totality of existence included in "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever." And in all one's intention, one should visualize in one's mind only the letters of the holy Names according to the time and place, for this alone is permitted.

פרק ט׳

Chapter 9

רמז מיתה הכתובה בתורה אם
לא חטא אדם הראשון:

A Reference to Death Written in the Torah Even If Adam Had Not Sinned:

קודם החטא ראוי היה אדם
הראשון להתלבש במיתה דכתיב
אדם כי ימות באהל אלא שהקדים
עצמו אליה שלא בעונתה ובפגם
שעשה בעצמו נפגמו כל הבאים
אחריו מפני אחיזתם בו וזה
סוד החטאת אם היתה פגול
או נותר אף הנוגע בה ובלע
ממנה יקדש כמותה ואם היה

Before the sin, Adam was destined to be clothed in death, as it is written, "When a man dies in a tent" (Numbers 19:14), but he hastened himself to it prematurely. Through the blemish he created in himself, all who came after him were also blemished because of their connection to him. This is the mystery of the sin-offering: if it became ritually unfit or remained beyond its time, even one who touches it and absorbs from it becomes sanctified like it. If he was already

[i] The caution that only visualization of divine names is permitted reflects Kabbalistic concerns about proper mystical practice, warning against anthropomorphic visualization of divinity which would be considered idolatrous.

[ii] Cf. Zohar — The entire passage draws heavily from Zoharic concepts of divine unification, particularly the union of masculine and feminine aspects of divinity (YHVH and ADNY). The metaphor of kissing as spiritual union is a classic Zoharic motif found in multiple sections. | Cf. Song of Songs — The verse 'Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth' from Song of Songs is interpreted here mystically as representing the union between the divine masculine and feminine aspects, a common kabbalistic reading of this biblical text. | Cf. Genesis 29:11 — The verse about Jacob kissing Rachel is reinterpreted here as a mystical allegory for divine unions between masculine and feminine aspects of divinity. | Cf. Psalms 18:11 — The verses about God riding on a cherub are interpreted as metaphors for the relationship between upper and lower divine realms. | Cf. Deuteronomy 6:4 — The Shema ('Hear O Israel') is presented as a central unification prayer that connects the Infinite with the sefirot. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The reference to 32 paths of wisdom is drawn from Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), an early mystical text that discusses the 32 paths formed by the 10 sefirot and 22 Hebrew letters.

קדוש מתקדש בקדושתה שכן כל מה שנכלל מהיכל לבנת הספיר ופנימה קדוש ומתאחד בסוד היחוד.[i] והמיתה היתה מכוונת מאתו יתברך באהל והיא גנוזה בקדש. מות וחיים בהדי הדדי[ii] והחטא כפל את המיתה והאכילה פגה והפליגה מן החיים וסוף סוף עצת ה׳ היא תקום וכבר דברנו במספיק במאמר ראשון ושני להוכיח כי אפילו המיתה הלזו היא תמימות ותיקון שאחר שהנשמות יפשיטו חומרם ויכנסו אל נפש העולם מדור הנשמות ויתעלו אל רוחו של עולם מקום ג״ע של מטה מציאות עולם המלאכים ויתעלו ממנו ובו דרך מציאותו עד יכנסו אל נשמתו של עולם סוד הכסא ויתאחזו בכסא בסוד מדור הנשמות למעלה מההיכלות. וזהו אמרם ז״ל גזרה על המת שישתכח מן הלב שגם שנגזר על הנפטר שיסתלק מן העולם הזה התחתון הוא לסלקו ממקום השכחה ששם אחיזת הקליפות בסוד רגליה יורדות מות ומתעלה ומשתכח מן הל״ב נתיבות התחתונים[iii] מתפשטים בעולם הכליון וההפסד ומתעלה לל״ב העליון שהוא עלמא דדכורא אשר עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך. ובן יהיה סוד נבואה בסוד תוכיותו של עולם בחלק המתלבש זה בתוך זה ובזה יהיה התפשטות המלאכים והתגלמם באויר לאברהם שראם בדמות אנשים וזה נדין בסוד האצילות ובמה שלמעלה ממנו שהוא חיות הכל בסוד

holy, he becomes sanctified through its holiness, for everything that is included within the Palace of the Sapphire Brick and inward is holy and unified in the mystery of divine unification. 15R

Death was intended by the Blessed One "in the tent" and is hidden in holiness. Death and life exist together, but sin doubled death, and premature consumption distanced humanity from life. Yet ultimately, the counsel of the Lord will stand. We have 20R already discussed sufficiently in the first and second discourses to prove that even this death is a perfection and rectification. After souls strip away their material substance, they enter the World-Soul, the dwelling place of souls, and ascend to the World-25R Spirit, the location of the lower Garden of Eden, the realm of angels. From there they ascend through its reality until they enter the Soul of the World, the mystery of the Throne, and attach themselves to the Throne in the mystery of the dwelling of souls above 30R the Heavenly Palaces.

This explains the sages' statement, "It is decreed that the dead be forgotten from the heart." Though it is decreed that the departed ascend from this lower world, this is to remove him from the place of for-35R getfulness, where the external forces (kelipot) grasp, as in "her feet descend to death" (Proverbs 5:5). He is elevated and forgotten from the thirty-two lower paths that extend into the world of destruction and decay, and ascends to the upper thirty-two, which is 40R the masculine realm that "no eye has seen, O God, besides You" (Isaiah 64:3).

Similarly, the mystery of prophecy exists in the inwardness of the world, in the part that clothes itself one within the other. Through this occurs the 45R extension of angels and their embodiment in the air, as when Abraham saw them in the form of men. This is judged in the mystery of Atzilut (Emanation) and what is above it, which is the life-force of all, in the mystery from above to below and from below 50R to above, and in the mystery of the Garden of Eden

[i] The 'mystery of divine unification' (sod ha-yichud) is a central kabbalistic concept referring to the cosmic union of masculine and feminine divine aspects, often symbolized by the unification of the divine names YHVH and Adonai.

[ii] This phrase 'death and life exist together' represents a key kabbalistic concept that death was part of the original divine plan, not merely a punishment for sin. This understanding is central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a spiritual transition rather than solely a tragedy.

[iii] The '32 lower paths' refers to the kabbalistic concept of the 32 paths of wisdom in their lower manifestation, representing how divine wisdom manifests in the physical world. The text contrasts this with the '32 upper paths' in the spiritual realm.

ממעלה למטה ובסוד מלמטה למעלה ובסוד ג״ע למעלה מהאצילו[i]ת:[ii]

above Atzilut.

פרק י׳

Chapter 10

משלש מתנות שניתנו על ידי יסורים א׳ מהם הוא העה״ב שהיא בינה שנטייתה אל השמאל ובהיותה מתהפכת לפעול כח הרחמים אי אפשר אם לא ינתן חלק לחצונים כעין ואתן אדם תחתיך וכך הטעם בתורה וארץ ישראל ולכן יוכרח שיוקדם לכל אחד מהם היסורין כי המקטרגים ירצו חלקם. ויסורי המיתה הוא חלק אשר לבחות ההם כענין חלק השטן באיוב והם הכנה לנקיית העולם הבא והקבר הבא אחר המיתה הוא כור גדול אל סיגי הגוף ולכן דור המדבר הוליכם שם ארבעים שנה אחר חטא המרגלים כי נדבקו לצרף ארבעים קליפות חסר א׳ הפך טל של ברכה כי לא יתעצם הדבר להיותו

Of the three gifts that are given through suffering, one of them is the World to Come, which is Binah (Understanding), whose inclination is toward the left side. When it turns to exert the power of mercy, this is impossible unless a portion is given to the external forces, as in the verse "I will give men in your place" (Isaiah 43:4). The same principle applies to Torah and the Land of Israel.[A] Therefore, it is necessary that suffering must precede each of these gifts, for the accusers demand their share.

The sufferings of death are the portion that belongs to these forces,[B] similar to Satan's portion in Job, and they serve as preparation for the purification needed for the World to Come. The grave that follows death is like a great crucible for the dross of the body. This is why the generation of the wilderness wandered there for forty years after the sin of the spies, for they needed to be refined from thirty-nine negative forces[C]—the opposite of the dew of blessing[D]—since nothing can attain a

[A] Or: "And this is the reason regarding Torah and the Land of Israel" — This alternative is more literal but slightly less fluent. The original translation better conveys the meaning that the same principle discussed applies to both Torah and the Land of Israel.

[B] Or: "And the sufferings of death are the share belonging to those powers" — This alternative is valid and perhaps slightly more literal, but the original translation better captures the technical kabbalistic meaning of 'forces' (kochot) as negative spiritual entities.

[C] Or: "to refine forty negative shells minus one" — The alternative is more literal in preserving the Hebrew phrase structure of 'forty minus one' and uses 'shells' (kelipot) which is the technical kabbalistic term, though the original translation is more accessible to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[D] Or: "contrary to the dew of blessing" — Both translations effectively convey the meaning, but

[i] The reference to 'the Garden of Eden above Atzilut' represents an unusual cosmological claim, as most kabbalistic systems place the Garden of Eden in the world of Beriah (Creation), below Atzilut (Emanation). This suggests the author is referring to a particularly elevated spiritual realm.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author references his earlier discussions in 'the first and second discourses' of Ma'avar Yabok, indicating this passage comes from a later section of the same work. | Cf. Numbers 19:14 — The verse 'Adam ki yamut ba'ohel' (When a man dies in a tent) is cited to support the kabbalistic claim that death was part of the divine plan even before Adam's sin. | Cf. Proverbs 5:5 — The reference to 'her feet descend to death' from Proverbs is used to characterize the realm of the kelipot (external forces) where souls can become trapped. | Cf. Isaiah 64:3 — The verse is used to describe the transcendent nature of the 'masculine realm' (alma de-dekhura) to which purified souls ascend after death. | Cf. Zohar — The passage's discussion of the 'Palace of the Sapphire Brick' (heikhal livnat ha-sapir) and the various worlds through which souls ascend draws on Zoharic cosmology, particularly the concept of souls ascending through multiple worlds after death.

במדרגה עליונה אם לא ירד
במדרגות התחתונות להצטרף.
ומקודם הם היו טהורים וברים
ולאהיתה הקליפה נאחזת בהם
מפני טהרתם אבל אחר חטא זה
הוצרכו להיות במדבר נחש שרף
ועקרב וצמאון להצטרף שם ולכן
היו חופרים להם קברים בכל
ערב ט׳ באב שאז היה מתגבר
כח הקליפה ההיא ובהכנס עצמם
בקברות היו משברים ומכתתים
אותה ובעולם הבא דור המדבר
בג״ע עושים כן לטהר עצמם
כדאמרו בינוקא וזה כדי להכין
עצמם לתחיה זכים וברים כראוי
להם שהיו שלימות הדורות
מתחלת העולם ועד הנה. והנה
עונש העבירות אינם על צד
הנקמה והעונש רק על דרך
הנקיות והצירוף ככביסת הבגד
שלפי לכלוכו כן ירבה כביסתו
וכן הוא אש הגהינם לנשמות
והנה הודיעונו חז״ל כי יש שבעה
מדרגות מיתה שבעה תמורות
שהם מיתה עוני שממה מלחמה
אולת כיעור עבדות כדפי׳
בספר יצירה והם שבעה עינים
נובעות גבורות. ונראה לדעתי
כי רמזו חז״ל ז׳ עיני גבורות
אלו במאמרם יום ראשון מיתה
של זעף לשני מיתה של בהלה
לשלישי מיתה של מגפה לרביעי
מיתה בהכרת לחמישי מיתה
הדופה לששי מיתה האמורה
בתורה לשביעי מיתה של חבה
יותר מכאן מיתחשל יסורין
וכשתדקדק בכל א׳ מדיני מיתות
אלו תבין כי הם שבעה עיינין
מתלהטן ממטה למעלה ולכן
מיתה האמורה בתורה היא בכח
מדת הגבורה והמיתה השביעית
שהיא על ידי חסד קראוה מיתה
של חבה והובא מאמר זה גם כן
במדרש תהלים ומשם נראה גם כן
בחובה לצדיק להתפלל כל ימיו
שלא יאסף בלא תשובה ושלא

higher level without first descending to lower levels to be purified.

Previously, they were pure and clear, and the negative forces could not attach to them because of their purity. But after this sin, they needed to be in "a wilderness of venomous snakes, scorpions, and thirst" (Deuteronomy 8:15) to be refined there. This is why they would dig graves for themselves every eve of the Ninth of Av, when the power of these negative forces intensified. By entering these graves, they would break and crush these forces. Similarly, in the World to Come, the generation of the wilderness in the Garden of Eden continues this process to purify themselves, as explained in the story of the Child in the Zohar. This is to prepare themselves for resurrection, pure and clear as befits them, for they represented the perfection of generations from the beginning of the world until then.

The punishment for transgressions is not for the sake of vengeance or punishment itself, but rather for cleansing and refinement, like washing a garment—the more soiled it is, the more washing it requires. This is the nature of the fires of Gehenna for souls. Our Sages have informed us that there are seven degrees of death, seven transformations, which are: death, poverty, desolation, war, foolishness, ugliness, and slavery, as explained in Sefer Yetzirah. These are the seven "eyes" that flow from the attribute of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment).

It seems to me that our Sages alluded to these seven eyes of Gevurah in their teaching: "On the first day, a death of wrath; on the second, a death of panic; on the third, a death of plague; on the fourth, a death of excision; on the fifth, a death of pushing; on the sixth, the death mentioned in the Torah; on the seventh, a death of affection; beyond this, a death of suffering." When you examine each of these types of death carefully, you will understand that they represent seven "eyes" that flame from below to above. Therefore, the death mentioned in the Torah is through the power of the attribute of Gevurah, while the seventh death, which comes through Chesed (Loving-kindness), they called a "death of affection." This teaching is also brought in Midrash Tehillim, which also indicates that it is obligatory for a righteous person to pray throughout his life

the alternative might be slightly clearer in conveying the contrast between the negative forces and the positive 'dew of blessing' concept in Kabbalah.

ימות ביום מיתת רשע כדדרשו
שם על פסוק אל תאסף עם
חטאים נפשי. וכנגד ז׳ גבורות
70 אלו יש ז׳ מדרגות של גיהנם
שהם ז׳ כחות כאומרו והכיתי
אתכם גם אני שבע ומאלו השבעה
יתפשטו מ״ב דינים חזקים
כדכתיב ויספתי ליסרה אתכם
75 שבע בחטאתיכם ועל כל פרטי
המיתה יש טעם וסוד כי מיתת
הנפלים ממעי אמן הוא למרק
הכריתות ומיתות בית דין וכן יש
טעם למתים מצד תאות אכילה
80 או מצד מלאכה יתירה. או
מחמת ביאת הזכר על המעוברת
הכל מוקבל נגד מה שנתחייבו
מצד אבותיהם וכן אם חייבים
סקילה נופלת האם ומפלת. אם
85 שריפה נכויה ומצערה ומפלת.
ולכן יש מעוברות שסבה קלה
מפלת אותן ויש שאינה מפלת
משום סבה. עוד יש טעם למתים
בקטנותם משעת לידה עד י״ג
90 שנה ויום א׳ ועליהם נאמר
ראיתי דמעת העשוקים. עוד
נתנו טעם בספר הזהר למתים
מבן י״ג עד עשרים ומיתת
אלו אינו על ידי אותו מלאך
95 המות הממית לגדולים ומיתת
הקטנים בבטן האם היא קלה כי
העובר במעי אמו אין לו אלא
הצלם שעל ידו נמתחים אבריו
והצלם קרוב מאד לחצונים
100 עד שהנפש הרוכבת עליו הוא
מהעשיה. ולכן החצונים בנקל
יפגמו בצלם וימיתוהו ובלדתו
מזדמן לו נפש ובהגיעו לחינוך
רוח מזדמן אליו וביי״ג נשמתו
105 מזדמנת אליו ויצא מכלל
החצונים ובשנת עשרים מגיע
למדרגת עולם האצילות ולכן
נקרא בן ונדון בב״ד של מעלה
והמתים מבן עשרים ולמעלה
110 הוא על ידי מלאך המות ממש כל
א׳ כפי מעשהו שאין מיתה בלא
חטא ואין באן מקום של דרושים
אלו רק די לנו להבין ולהורות
כי הכל משוער ונמדד וקו המדה

not to be gathered without repentance and not to die the death of a wicked person, as they interpreted there the verse "Do not gather my soul with sinners" (Psalms 26:9). 70R

Corresponding to these seven powers of Gevurah are seven levels of Gehenna, which are seven forces, as it says, "I will strike you, even I, seven times" (Leviticus 26:28). From these seven extend forty-two strong judgments, as it is written, "I will continue to 75R discipline you seven times for your sins" (Leviticus 26:21). There is a reason and mystery behind every particular aspect of death. The death of miscarriages from their mother's womb serves to cleanse away the punishments of spiritual excision and capital pun- 80R ishments. Similarly, there are reasons for deaths caused by excessive eating or excessive labor, or from a man having relations with a pregnant woman—all corresponding to what they were liable for due to their ancestors. Thus, if they are liable to stoning, 85R the mother falls and miscarries; if burning, she is scorched, suffers, and miscarries. This is why some pregnant women miscarry from a minor cause while others do not miscarry for any reason.

There is also a reason for those who die in child- 90R hood, from birth until thirteen years and one day, of whom it is said, "I saw the tears of the oppressed" (Ecclesiastes 4:1). The Zohar also gives a reason for those who die between thirteen and twenty years. The death of these is not through the same Angel of 95R Death that kills adults. The death of infants in their mother's womb is easier because the fetus has only the tzelem (divine image) through which its limbs are formed, and this tzelem is very close to the external forces, while the soul riding upon it is from 100R the World of Asiyah (Action). Therefore, the external forces can easily damage the tzelem and cause death. At birth, a nefesh (vital soul) becomes available to the child; when reaching the age of education, a ruach (spirit) becomes available; at thirteen, the 105R neshamah (higher soul) becomes available, and the child emerges from the category of external forces; at twenty, one reaches the level of the World of Atzilut (Emanation), thus becoming fully accountable and judged by the heavenly court. Those who die from 110R twenty years and up die through the Angel of Death itself, each according to their deeds, for there is no death without sin.

This is not the place for these inquiries; it is

המהוה את הכל ומי יוכל לעמוד
על דיניו של הקב״ה כי מאד
עמקו מחשבותיו ויש יסורין של
אהבה שירצה אהבת צדק ומשפט
זה לזה ויסורין שאינן של אהבה
הם בפירוד צדק ממשפט ויש
עוד יסורין של אהבה שאינם על
עון:[i]

enough for us to understand and teach that everything is measured and calculated by the measuring line that forms everything. Who can comprehend the judgments of the Holy One, blessed be He, for His thoughts are exceedingly deep. There are sufferings of love, which express the love between righteousness and justice;[A] and there are sufferings not of love, which occur when righteousness is separated from justice. There are also sufferings of love that are not for sin.

פרק י״א

Chapter 11

הכחות שמהם מתהוה המיתה
הם מבחינת גל עד[ii] ולמטה
כי כחה קדושה מתפשטת עד
בחינת גל עד הנזכר ועד שם
מתלבשת בלבוש חצוני ונקרא
יגר שהדותא ולבן הארמי שם
הוא מקום אחיזתו ואינו עובר
משם ולמעלה ויעקב מגיע עד
גלעד ואינו עובר משם ולמטה
והיינו אם אתה לא תעבור וגו׳
וגם אני לא אעבור וזהו סוד
לקיטת האבנים שעד שם הוא סוד
האבנים והאכילה היא שם על
הגל אלו אוכלים בקדושה ואלו
אוכלים מחוץ ומשם הדברים
נפרדים אל הקדושים מצד
אחד ואל החצונים מצד אחר

The forces from which death originates derive from the level of Gal-Ed (“heap of witness”) and below, for its holy power extends only as far as the aforementioned level of Gal-Ed. At that point, it becomes clothed in an external garment and is called “Yegar Sahaduta” (the Aramaic equivalent of Gal-Ed). This is where Laban the Aramean has his hold, and he cannot cross beyond that point upward. Similarly, Jacob reaches only as far as Gilead and cannot cross downward from there. This is the meaning of “if you do not cross over, etc., neither will I cross over.”[1] This is the secret of the gathering of stones, for up to that point is the mystery of the stones, and the meal takes place there upon the heap—these eating in holiness and those eating outside. From that point, matters separate toward the holy forces on one side and toward the external forces on the other.

[A] Or: “when righteousness and justice love one another” — The alternative translation more clearly personifies the divine attributes of Tzedek (Righteousness) and Mishpat (Justice) as loving each other, which better reflects the kabbalistic understanding of divine attributes interacting with each other.

[1] This references Genesis 31:52 where Jacob and Laban make a covenant that neither will cross the stone heap to harm the other. The author is using this as a mystical metaphor for the boundary between higher and lower spiritual realms.

[i] Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The author references Sefer Yetzirah to support his explanation of the seven degrees of death, grounding his mystical interpretation in a canonical kabbalistic text. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim — The author cites this midrash to establish the obligation for the righteous to pray that they not die without repentance or die like the wicked. | Cf. Zohar, Story of the Child (Yanuka) — The reference connects the purification process of the generation of the wilderness in the afterlife to kabbalistic teachings about soul refinement found in the Zohar. | Cf. Book of Job — The author uses the example of Satan’s role in Job’s suffering to explain how negative spiritual forces are allowed a portion in the suffering of death as part of the divine plan. | Cf. Leviticus 26:21,28 — These verses are cited to demonstrate the concept of seven levels of judgment that correspond to the seven levels of Gehenna.

[ii] The Hebrew term ‘Gal-Ed’ (heap of witness) appears in Genesis 31:47-48 where Jacob and Laban make a covenant, with Laban using the Aramaic equivalent ‘Yegar Sahaduta.’ In Kabbalah, this becomes a metaphor for the boundary between holy and profane realms.

וכן נאמר במכירת יוסף ארחת ישמעאלים באה מגלעד. ואמרו שכמו שיוסף נטה עד פוטיפר[i] גם יהודה נטה עד איש עדולמי ונשא אשה שאינה הוגנת לו והוליד בנים למטה עד מסוד עץ הדעת טוב ורע[ii] השני אונן מקום האנינות והיינו למטה סוד עולם האופנים א׳ ממשלת היום לכן נאמר בו ויקרא וא׳ ממשלת הלילה לכן נאמר בו ותקרא וכן שבעה היכלות מתלבשים בשבעה מדורין. ושלה הוא מקום השלי והוא בנגד עולם הזה ומה שאירע ליוסף עם אחיו ובפרט עם יהודה הכל דוגמא למה שיתהוה בין משיח בן יוסף ובין משיח בן דוד דרוש משם ותראה ותבין עם מאמרי רז״ל האומרים כי הנה המלכים נועדו וכו׳ וקליפת נוגה[iii] היתה מצע קדוש המבדלת בין הקדושה ובין המצריים שהיא קדושה מצד פנימה ואינה חוששת מן החצונים מצד החוץ להיותה בעין קליפת האילן שמתייחסת מצד חוץ והמים ומצד פנים מתייחסת אל האילן להגין ונרמז זה במלת יעקב יו״ד עקב איש וביתו באו ובחינת שם יעקב גלה למצרים אבל לא בחינת ישראל ובשעת מיתתו האיר בחינת ישראל לבחינת יעקב[iv] ויוסף

Thus it is said regarding the sale of Joseph: "A caravan of Ishmaelites came from Gilead." And they said that just as Joseph descended as far as Potiphar, so too Judah descended to the Adullamite and married a woman unsuitable for him, begetting sons even further below, from the realm of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil. The second son, Onan, represents the place of mourning (aninot), corresponding to the lower realm of the world of the Ophanim (Wheels). One rules by day, thus it is written "and he called," while one rules by night, thus it is written "and she called."[1] Similarly, seven palaces clothe themselves in seven dwelling places.[2]

Shelah corresponds to the afterbirth, parallel to this world. What happened to Joseph with his brothers, particularly with Judah, is all a model for what will transpire between Messiah son of Joseph and Messiah son of David. Study this matter and you will understand the rabbinic statement that "the kings assembled together," etc. The translucent shell (kelipat nogah) was a holy buffer separating the sacred from the Egyptians—being holy from its inner side while unconcerned with external forces from the outside, like the bark of a tree that relates to the outside elements and water, while from the inside it relates to the tree for protection.

This is alluded to in the word "Jacob" (יעקב): yod-heel[3]—"a man and his household came." The aspect of the name Jacob went down to Egypt, but not the aspect of Israel. At the time of his death, the aspect of Israel illuminated the aspect of Jacob. Joseph embodied the secret of the concealed

[1] The author is making a distinction between the masculine "and he called" (ויקרא) associated with daytime rule and the feminine "and she called" (ותקרא) associated with nighttime rule, reflecting the kabbalistic principle of masculine and feminine divine energies governing different cosmic domains.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of seven celestial palaces (heichalot) that manifest in seven corresponding domains in the lower worlds, creating a symmetry between higher and lower realms.

[3] The author is engaging in a kabbalistic wordplay on the name יעקב (Jacob), interpreting it as composed of the letter yod (י) plus the word 'heel' (עקב), suggesting that Jacob represents the divine aspect (yod) that descends to the lowest level (heel).

[i] The text draws a parallel between Joseph's descent to Egypt (to Potiphar's house) and Judah's descent to the Adullamite, interpreting both as spiritual descents into lower realms.

[ii] The 'Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil' is being used here metaphorically to represent a mixed realm where both holiness and impurity exist, corresponding to lower spiritual levels.

[iii] In Kabbalistic thought, 'kelipat nogah' (the translucent shell) is a unique type of 'kelipah' (shell/husk) that contains both good and evil elements. Unlike purely negative kelipot, it can be elevated to holiness. It serves as a buffer zone between sacred and profane realms.

[iv] In Kabbalah, the names 'Jacob' and 'Israel' represent different spiritual states of the same entity—'Jacob' indicates a lower spiritual level while 'Israel' represents a higher, more perfected state, as reflected in Genesis 32:28 when Jacob's name is changed to Israel after wrestling with the angel.

היה בסוד האבר המתעלם שאין שולט בו הגלות ותמיד היה עומד בצדקו והוא מיחד בין בחינת ישראל לבחינת יעקב ועצת מצרים על ישראל היה דוגמא עצת דור הפלגה להגביר החצונים ושישראל לא יתאחזו בקדש פן יתגברו עליהם וכוונו שיבנו ערים שאוצרים בהם עוני לישראל והאלהים חשבה לטובה:[i]

limb[1] over which exile has no dominion; he always remained steadfast in his righteousness, unifying the aspect of Israel with the aspect of Jacob. Egypt's plot against Israel paralleled the scheme of the Generation of Dispersion—to empower the external forces and prevent Israel from taking hold of the sacred, lest they prevail over them. They intended for them to build cities that would store poverty for Israel, but God turned it to good.

פרק י״ב

Chapter 12

קצת מכוונת התעוררות שעושה המתפלל על החולה[ii] או על כל צרה שלא תבא ולתקון חטא עון ופשע:[iii] [iv]

Some Aspects of the Awakening Intention[2] That One Who Prays Makes for the Sick Person or for Any Calamity That May Not Come,[3] and for the Rectification of Transgression, Iniquity, and Willful Sin:[4]

[1] In kabbalistic symbolism, Joseph is associated with the divine attribute of Yesod (Foundation), often represented as the phallus or 'concealed limb' that channels divine flow. The text suggests that this attribute remains unaffected by exile or negative spiritual forces.

[2] The Hebrew term התעוררות (awakening/arousal) has special significance in Kabbalah, referring to the cosmic process where human actions below stimulate response from divine forces above. Prayer is understood as creating an 'awakening from below' (אתערותא דלתתא) that triggers an 'awakening from above' (אתערותא דלעילא).

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'צרה שלא תבא' is a euphemistic way of referring to potential troubles while simultaneously expressing the hope that they will not materialize. This reflects the Jewish belief that words have power and should be used cautiously when discussing negative possibilities.

[4] This translation preserves the traditional rabbinic understanding of the three Hebrew terms as

[i] Cf. Genesis 31:47-52 — The author uses this story as a mystical metaphor for the boundary between sacred and profane realms, with Laban representing external forces that cannot ascend beyond this point, while Jacob (representing holiness) cannot descend below it. | Cf. Genesis 37:25 — The author connects this to the mystical boundary of Gilead, suggesting that the sale of Joseph represented a descent from higher to lower spiritual realms. | Cf. Genesis 38:1-5 — The author interprets Judah's marriage to a Canaanite woman as a spiritual descent parallel to Joseph's journey to Egypt, with each son representing different spiritual levels. | Cf. Zohar — The author employs the Zoharic concept of 'kelipat nogah' (the translucent shell) as an intermediary realm between sacred and profane, comparing it to tree bark that protects the inner tree while interacting with external elements. | Cf. Psalms 48:5 — The author references rabbinic interpretations of this verse, suggesting it contains mystical allusions to the relationship between Messiah son of Joseph and Messiah son of David. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse Two — This passage elaborates on the book's central metaphor of 'crossing' between realms, explaining the spiritual mechanics of how death occurs at the boundary between divine and mundane realms.

[ii] The Hebrew term used here refers not just to any ill person but specifically to someone seriously ill, which in kabbalistic thought represents someone under the influence of harsh divine judgment that requires spiritual intervention.

[iii] This threefold formula represents increasingly severe levels of sin in rabbinic tradition: חטא (unintentional transgression), עון (deliberate iniquity), and פשע (rebellious sin). The author will explain how each requires a different level of spiritual repair through prayer.

[iv] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse One, Chapter 10 — The author refers back to his earlier discussion about the spiritual efficacy of morning prayer, suggesting that this section builds upon previously established principles about proper prayer timing. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse One, Chapters 12 and 15 — The author explicitly references his earlier discussion of confession (vidui) for the sick, showing how the current section on prayer intentions builds upon his previous treatment of proper spiritual care for the ill.

הזהירו גורי האר״י במנהגיו
שאם יש איזה חבר בצרה ח״ו
או חולה ישתתף בצערו ויתפלל
עליו וכן בכל דבריו ישתתף
חבריו עמו. וכיון דאתא לידן
נימא מילתא בסוד התעוררות
בתפלה. וזה כי מדי עלותה
תעורר הרצון העליון[i] ויתעוררו
תלתא מוחין שבחכמה בתלת
חללין. אחד מצד הבינה שבו
צד השמיעה כוללת. הב׳ מוח
המעורר העינים והיא בחינה
עליונה אשר למוח שהיא בחכמה.
הג׳ מוח המעורר הדבור והוא
בסוד הדעת. ובתפלה יתעוררו
המוחין הנזכרים התעוררות
טוב כי ממעלה למטה יתעורר
הכתר ביסוד שהוא רצון כנודע
וימשיך סוד הרצון אל הבינה על
ידי החכמה. והבינה מתעוררת
על ידי התעוררות ההוא ואז
מצד הבינה יתעורר למטה סוד
גולגלתא במוחין דלגאו ואז
יעשה שמיעת התפלה וקבלתה
ברצון ויתפשט אז המציאות אל
העקמימות שנתעקם בספירות
וצורת העקמימות הוא צורת

The disciples of the ARI[A] cautioned in his customs[1] that if any colleague is in distress, God forbid, or ill, one should share in his suffering and pray for him, and likewise in all one's affairs, one should involve one's companions. And since this matter has come to our hands,[B] let us discuss the secret of arousal through prayer. When prayer ascends, it awakens the Supernal Will and arouses the three aspects of consciousness within Wisdom in the three chambers.[2] One is from the aspect of Understanding within it, which is the comprehensive aspect of hearing. The second is the consciousness that arouses the eyes, which is the higher aspect of the mind that is in Wisdom. The third is the consciousness that arouses speech, which is in the mystery of Knowledge. During prayer, these aspects of consciousness are awakened in a positive manner, for from above to below, the Crown is aroused in Foundation, which is Will,[3] as is known, and it draws the mystery of Will to Understanding through Wisdom. And Understanding is aroused through this awakening, and then from the aspect of Understanding, the mystery of the Skull is aroused below in the inner minds,[4] and then the prayer is heard and accepted willingly. Then the divine flow extends to the distortions that have become crooked in the sefiro[C]t, and the form of this crookedness is

[A] Or: "the students of Rabbi Isaac Luria" — While 'disciples of the ARI' is accurate, using 'students of Rabbi Isaac Luria' provides clarity for readers who might not be familiar with the acronym ARI (which stands for 'the divine Rabbi Isaac').

[B] Or: "and since this topic has presented itself to us" — The Aramaic phrase is idiomatic, and while 'come to our hands' is a literal translation, 'this topic has presented itself to us' better conveys the meaning in natural English.

[C] Or: "divine flow to the distortions that have occurred within the sefirot" — The original trans-

representing a hierarchy of sins: חטא (transgression) refers to unintentional mistakes, עון (iniquity) to conscious wrongdoing, and פשע (willful sin) to deliberate rebellion against divine will.

[1] The ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria, 1534-1572) was the preeminent kabbalist of Safed whose teachings revolutionized Jewish mysticism. His disciples recorded and systematized his oral teachings after his death.

[2] In Lurianic Kabbalah, the divine intellect is composed of three aspects called 'mochin' (consciousnesses): Chokhmah (Wisdom), Binah (Understanding), and Da'at (Knowledge), which correspond to different modes of divine intelligence.

[3] This refers to Keter (Crown) manifesting in Yesod (Foundation). In Kabbalah, Keter represents the highest divine will, while Yesod channels divine flow to Malkhut (Kingdom). This describes how divine will begins to manifest in the cosmos through prayer.

[4] The 'Skull' (Gulgalta) refers to the highest aspect of Keter, while 'inner minds' (mochin d'legau) are the internalized consciousnesses within the divine configuration. This describes how prayer activates the innermost aspects of divine consciousness.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that prayer, as it ascends, awakens the Supernal Will (Ratzon Elyon), the highest level of divine desire that initiates the flow of blessing.

תרועה אוחז בימין ושמאל מצד
דרכי בני אדם המעקם הקול
העולה ויתפשטו עד התחתונים
35 להזמין אותם הממונים לקבלת
תפלת התחתונים שהם בעלי
כנפים כי עליהם נאמר כי עוף
השמים יוליך את הקול ובעל
כנפים יגיד דבר.[i] הנה כי בתפלת
40 וזעקת התחתונים יתמתקו
הדינים והגבורה העליונה והיינו
בהיות הענין נתקן משרשו.
ויש ג׳ בחינות לחסדים כדי
למתק הדינים[ii] לבל יונבע הדין
45 בתוספת שאז הוא בהסכמת
הבינה. ומשם מתגלגל ח״ו דרך
המדרגות והחיכלות ומשם על
החצונים כי הם באים ומלקקים
הדם ופועלים הדין והיינו
50 קץ כל בשר בא לפני. הבחינה
הראשונה. יכוין המתפלל לעורר
חסדי היסוד שהוא חסד בסוד
החסדים העליונים. ולתקון
החטא שוגג די לעורר החסד זה
55 לטהר המ׳ ולהמשיך לה היסוד
ומקור גבורתיה ישתככו וימתקו
בהכנס החסד הזה אליהם אחר
שאין שום דין מתגבר בזכר.
הבחינה הב׳ כאשר הדינים
60 מהגבורה מסבת העון מזיד
החסד ימין יעורר בלובן חסדיו
מן השרשים העליונים אחר
שפנים העליונים בישובן ואינם
בכעס די בהמתקת הגבורה הזאת
65 ומשם אל הגבורה התחתונים

like the form of the teruah [shofar blast], grasping both right and left,[1] corresponding to the ways of humans who bend the rising voice, and they extend to the lower realms to summon those appointed 35R
to receive the prayers of those below, who are the winged ones, for of them it is said: "For a bird of the sky will carry the voice, and a winged creature will tell the matter." Thus, through the prayer and outcry of those below, the judgments and 40R
the supernal Strength will be sweetened,[A] that is, when the matter is repaired from its root. And there are three aspects of Kindness to sweeten the judgments so that judgment will not flow with increased severity, which would then be with the 45R
consent of Understanding. From there it would, God forbid, roll down through the levels and the palaces and from there onto the external forces, for they come and lick the blood and execute judgment, which is "the end of all flesh has come before Me." 50R
The first aspect: the one praying should intend to arouse the kindnesses of Foundation, which is Kindness in the mystery of the supernal Kindnesses. And to rectify an unintentional sin, it is enough to arouse this Kindness to purify Malkhut and 55R
draw to it the Foundation, and the source of its strengths will be calmed and sweetened when this Kindness enters them, since no judgment intensifies in the masculine. The second aspect: when the judgments are from Strength due to intentional 60R
sin, the Kindness of the right will arouse with the whiteness of its kindnesses from the supernal roots, since the supernal countenance is in its settled state and not in anger. It is enough to sweeten this Strength and from there to the lower Strength 65R

lation is overly literal. In kabbalistic context, this refers to the restoration of proper divine flow that has been disrupted or distorted within the cosmic channels (sefirot), not physical crookedness.

[A] Or: "the harsh judgments and the supernal Gevurah will be transformed into mercy" — The kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgments' (mituk ha-dinim) refers specifically to transforming harsh divine judgments into mercy. Including the Hebrew term 'Gevurah' and clarifying the transformation process provides more precision and context.

[1] The teruah is a series of short, staccato blasts on the shofar (ram's horn). Its broken pattern is compared to the distortions in divine flow that prayer aims to repair, affecting both the right side (mercy) and left side (judgment) of the divine structure.

[i] This is a quote from Ecclesiastes 10:20, which in its literal context warns against speaking ill of others because word might spread unexpectedly. In kabbalistic interpretation, it is understood as referring to angelic beings that carry prayers upward.

[ii] The text outlines a three-tiered system for 'sweetening judgments' (mituk ha-dinim), a key kabbalistic concept referring to the transformation of divine severity into mercy. Each tier corresponds to a different type of transgression requiring different levels of spiritual correction.

על ידי היסוד הנמתק ומתיחד עם המל׳. הבחינה הג׳ כאשר הדינים מהבינה מחמת הפשע שאז הם מתעוררים מרישא דמלכא צריך התקון מהכתר גולגלתא חיוורא קדישא סתימא.[i] משם יתעוררו החסדים העליונים ויתמתקו בשרשים הנסתרים ומשם על הגבורה ומשם לגבורה התחתונה. וזה בהקשר ג׳ חסדים גדולים בג׳ גבורות. חסד בכתר והחכמה בבינה חסד ממש בגבורה חסד היסוד במלכות ובזה יומתקו כל הגבורות וזה סוד תקונם דרך כלל. ויש משפטים לאין קץ:[ii]

through the Foundation that is sweetened and unified with Malkhut. The third aspect: when the judgments are from Understanding due to rebellious transgression, then they are aroused from the Head of the King, and the rectification must come from the Crown, the holy, concealed white skull.[1] From there the supernal Kindnesses will be aroused and will be sweetened in the hidden roots, and from there to Strength, and from there to the lower Strength. And this is through the connection of three great Kindnesses to three Strengths:[2] Kindness in the Crown and Wisdom in Understanding, actual Kindness in Strength, and the Kindness of Foundation in Malkhut. Through this, all the Strengths will be sweetened, and this is the mystery of their rectification in general. And there are judgments without end.

פרק י״ג

Chapter 13

ביסום הגבורות ע״י צדיק אחד או צדיקים הרבה[iii] וטעם לסדר

Sweetening the Powers of Judgment[A] Through One Righteous Person or Many Righteous People,[B] and

[A] Or: “Tempering the Severities” — The term ‘bisum’ (sweetening) in Kabbalistic terminology refers to the transformation of harsh divine judgment into mercy. An alternate translation might use ‘tempering’ to convey this metaphysical process of softening judgment.

[B] Or: “By Means of a Single Tzaddik or Multiple Tzaddikim” — The Hebrew term ‘tzaddik’ has specific connotations in Jewish mysticism that aren’t fully captured by ‘righteous person.’ Retaining the Hebrew term might be preferable in a translation aimed at readers familiar with Kabbalistic terminology.

[1] Gulgalta Chivra Kadisha Stima (holy, concealed white skull) refers to the highest aspect of Keter, the ultimate source of divine mercy that can transform even the most severe judgments. This represents the deepest level of divine compassion.

[2] This describes the kabbalistic process of balancing the divine attributes of Chesed (Kindness) and Gevurah (Strength/Judgment) at multiple levels of the divine structure, creating harmony throughout the sefirot.

[i] This refers to the ‘Holy Hidden White Skull,’ a concept from Lurianic Kabbalah representing the highest aspect of Keter (Crown), the first and most elevated sefirah. It is the source of divine mercy that can transform even the most severe judgments.

[ii] Cf. Shaar HaKavanot — This passage appears to draw directly from the Lurianic kabbalistic system detailed in Shaar HaKavanot, particularly regarding how prayer activates specific configurations in the upper worlds. | Cf. Zohar III:223b — This passage parallels the Zohar’s description of prayer as a cosmic mechanism that activates the sefirot and causes divine flow to descend from higher to lower realms. | Cf. Etz Chaim — The threefold structure of consciousness (mochin) mentioned here directly references the Lurianic system outlined in Etz Chaim, where the three mochin correspond to Chokhmah, Binah, and Da’at. | Cf. Kohelet 10:20 — The author uses this biblical verse as a proof text for the mystical concept that angelic beings (described as ‘winged ones’) are the agents that carry prayers from earth to heaven.

[iii] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that certain exceptional individuals (tzaddikim) have the spiritual power to affect cosmic forces directly, while in other cases a collective of righteous people is needed to achieve the same effect.

תפלת חולים בכלל:[i][ii]

the Reason for the Order of Prayers for the Sick in General:

אמנם התקון יהיה לפעמים ע״י
איש צדיק גבור לעמוד בפרץ
שמעמיד הגבורות בסוד היחודים
שעושה ומיחד תמיד הצדק עם
המשפט שלא יפרדו ועליה׳
נאמר צדיק מושל יראת אלהים
וכל יופי המל׳ מתוך מעשה
הצדיקים ומה גם המלמדים
תורה ברבים שהם כשדים ימין
ושמאל ומשפיעים תורה לרבים
יין וחלב וזהו צרור המור
דודי לי בין שדי ילין כי הוא
מתתקנת בסוד עוסקי תורה
ובסוד חכמה ותבונה ודעת והיא
סוגה מכחות החצונים. בשושנים
פי׳ בזכות ששונים. וסוד אבילת
הכהנים הקדשים והבעלים
מתכפרים מורה על חלוק השפע
במדרגות תחתונות ובזה יורו
קשר העולמות ותקונם מפגם
החומא שסלק השפע מהעליונים
והתחתונים ולזה אבילת קדשי
קדשים במקום קדוש וקדשים
במקום טהור וכו׳ ולכן הכהן
הטהור המחטא את הכלה
ומטהרה לבעלה. יאכלנה שהוא

However, the rectification sometimes comes through a righteous person who is mighty enough to stand in the breach,[A] who establishes the powers of Gevurah through the secret of the unifications[B] he performs, constantly uniting Righteousness with Justice so they do not separate. Concerning such individuals it is said, "The righteous rules through the fear of God." All the beauty of Malkhut comes from the deeds of the righteous, especially those who teach Torah to the multitudes, who are like breasts—right and left—flowing with Torah to the masses like wine and milk. This is the meaning of "My beloved is to me a bundle of myrrh that lies between my breasts," for She [the Shekhinah] is adorned through those who engage in Torah study, through wisdom, understanding, and knowledge, and thus She is protected from external forces. "Among the lilies" means "through the merit of those who study [Torah]."

The secret of the priests eating the sacred offerings while the owners receive atonement demonstrates how divine influence is distributed through the lower levels, thereby revealing the connection between worlds and their rectification from the blemish caused by the sinner who removed divine flow from upper and lower realms. This is why the most sacred

[A] Or: "to repair the breach" — The Hebrew phrase can also be translated more literally as 'to repair the breach,' emphasizing the active role of the righteous person in repairing cosmic damage rather than merely standing guard. This might be preferable in contexts emphasizing tikkun (repair).

[B] Or: "who stabilizes the powers of judgment through mystical unifications" — This alternate translation uses more accessible terminology for readers less familiar with kabbalistic terms like 'Gevurah,' while 'stabilizes' might better capture the meaning of מעמיד in this context of controlling potentially destructive forces.

[i] This refers to the eight structured prayer sequences (sedarim) presented in the first discourse of Ma'avar Yabok, which are carefully arranged collections of psalms and biblical verses for healing the sick.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 3, Chapter 15 — This passage connects to earlier discussions in Ma'avar Yabok about how the righteous can affect cosmic forces. The concept of 'sweetening judgments' appears throughout the work as a central kabbalistic framework for understanding how proper ritual and prayer can transform divine severity into mercy. | Cf. Zohar III:65a — The author is drawing on the Zoharic concept that righteous individuals can 'sweeten' divine judgments through their spiritual power. The Zohar teaches that the righteous have the ability to stand against harsh decrees and transform them, which forms the theological foundation for this passage. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 1, Chapter 30 — The reference to 'the order of prayers for the sick' directly connects to the first discourse's detailed presentation of eight structured liturgical sequences designed for healing. This passage appears to explain the metaphysical mechanism by which these prayers operate.

נוטל חלק בראש מהיחיד יושפע עליו חלקו עם נערותיה. ואם אין צדיק בארץ צריך שהרבים יעשו תשובה ותפלה ויתייחדו המדות בזכות הרבים. ומתח הדין ולכן הזהרתי במעירי שחר על כנוס שלמים וכן רבים להעתיר אל ה׳ קודם אור היום וכמה היה זהיר בזה החכם האר״י וסוף דבר עקר המתקת הדינים אינו תלוי אלא ביחוד הנ׳ וכניסת היסוד על המל׳ שהוא אשד הגבורות והתמתקם על ידי היסוד ולזה יכוין המתפלל על החולים ועל כל צרה שלא תבא וכוונת ההויות בנקודים ובגוונים ושאר פרטים המכוונות לזה לא אעלם על ספר וחמבין יבין מדעתו על פי ההקדמות ומפתחות המסורים בידו והמתקת הדינים הוא ע״י יחוד יסוד במלכות כי יסוד סוד לובן העליון מהוה בזכר והנקבה מזרעת אודם ואז יתקרבו הדינים עם החסדים והחסדים הם נמשכים ונגרים בחזקה עד שמתגברין על הדינין וכופין אותם ואז יתלבנו ונודע כי הדינים הקשים הקדושים יש להם הלבנינות בשרשים אשר להם למעלה מעלה ובשנטהרים יעורר הלבנינות ההוא ויתקשרו יחד ובהתקשרו ינוחו מרתיחת הדינים על כן אין קפידה בשום פועל לבטלה בטיפת שכבת זרע שמעלין על החוטא כהורג נפשות ומזה יובן למשכילים טעם הזווג בלילי שבת ואין כאן מקום דרוש זה:[i]

offerings must be eaten in a holy place and ordinary sacred offerings in a place of purity, etc. Therefore, the pure priest who purifies the bride and cleanses her for her husband[A] eats of the offering because he takes the first portion from the individual, and his share is bestowed upon him along with her maidens.

If there is no righteous person in the land, the community must perform repentance and prayer, and the divine attributes will be unified through the merit of the many, tempering the judgment. Therefore, I warned in my "Illuminators of Dawn" about gathering the perfect ones and many others to entreat the Lord before daybreak. How careful the sage the ARI was about this! In conclusion, the essential sweetening of judgments depends solely on the unification of Malkhut and the entry of Yesod into Malkhut, which is the confluence of the powers of Gevurah, which are sweetened through Yesod. This should be the intention of one who prays for the sick and for averting any calamity. The specific intentions regarding the divine names with their vowel points and colors, and other details focused on this purpose, I will not commit to writing. The discerning one will understand these matters through the principles and keys already entrusted to him.

The sweetening of judgments occurs through the unification of Yesod with Malkhut, for Yesod contains the secret of the supernal whiteness manifested in the masculine, while the feminine emanates redness. Then the judgments draw close to the mercies, and the mercies flow with great strength until they overpower the judgments and subdue them, causing them to be whitened.[B] It is known that the harsh holy judgments possess whiteness in their highest roots, and when they are purified, that whiteness is awakened and they become bound together. When they are bound, they rest from the intensity of the judgments. Therefore, there is no concern about any

[A] Or: "Therefore, the pure priest who removes sin from the bride and purifies her for her husband" — The Hebrew מחטא more specifically means 'to remove sin' rather than just 'purify,' which captures the specific ritual function being described and preserves the distinction between מחטא and מטהרה.

[B] Or: "and then they are transformed to whiteness" — This alternate translation better captures the transformative process described in the Kabbalistic concept of 'whitening' judgments, emphasizing the change of state rather than just coloration.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse, Chapter 30 — This reference expands the earlier discussion about Torah's healing properties by explaining its mechanism through Kabbalistic imagery of the 'breasts' (right and left sides of mercy and judgment) flowing divine energy. | Cf. Zohar,

act being in vain, such as a drop of seed, for which the sinner is considered as if he had killed souls. From this, the wise will understand the reason for marital union on Sabbath nights, but this is not the place to explore this topic. 70R

פרק י״ד

Chapter 14

נקודת המ׳ שהיא דינים חזקים[i] היא בית קבול לנקודת הזכר שהם חסדים ונקודה זו שבנקבה נקראת נקודת ציון[ii] שהיא הבחינה המשתווה להיות הדינים והחסדים מציאות אחד וענין א׳ ואין לדינים שום מציאות להתמתקם אלא מתוך נקודה זו שהיא נקודת ההשואה אשר אל החסד ואל הגבורה יחד במציאות הגבורות הקשות אשר בנקבה כי בחינת ב׳ זרועות יש להם דרך הכרעה אחרת ומי החסדים עליונים מטהרים קומת

The point of Malkhut, which embodies strong judgments,[A] serves as a receptacle for the masculine point, which embodies mercies. This point within the feminine is called "the point of Zion,"[B] representing the balancing dimension where judgments and mercies become a single reality and unified matter. The judgments have no means to be sweetened except through this point,[C] which is the point of equilibrium between Chesed and Gevurah[1] together, working within the harsh powers that exist in the feminine. The two arms (representing divine attributes) have a different way of mediation, while the upper waters of mercy purify the structure of the feminine, which corresponds to the letters of 5R 10R

[A] Or: "The point of Malkhut, which contains powerful judgments" — The Hebrew term 'dinim' (judgments) often refers to restrictive divine forces in Kabbalah, and 'contains' might be a more literal translation than 'embodies,' though both capture the essential meaning.

[B] Or: "the point of Tzion" — While 'Zion' is the common English spelling, 'Tzion' more accurately represents the Hebrew pronunciation and maintains consistency with other transliterations of Hebrew terms with the tzadi letter.

[C] Or: "The judgments have no existence by which they can be sweetened except through this point" — This translation better captures the nuance of 'metzi'ut' (existence/reality) in the original text, emphasizing that the judgments literally cannot exist in a sweetened state except through this point.

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'the middle pillar' where opposing divine forces are harmonized. While typically associated with Tiferet, here the author is describing a similar balancing function within Malkhut itself.

Parashat Terumah — The author is drawing upon classic Zoharic imagery of divine unification through righteous actions, especially the metaphor of the bundle of myrrh between the breasts from Song of Songs, which the Zohar interprets as the Divine Presence being adorned through Torah study. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The author builds on the Tikkunei Zohar's framework of mitigating harsh cosmic judgments through proper spiritual intentions that unite Yesod (masculine) and Malkhut (feminine) divine attributes. | Cf. Song of Songs 1:13 — The author uses this biblical verse as interpreted in kabbalistic tradition to illustrate how the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) is adorned through Torah study, which creates the 'breasts' (channels of divine flow) that sustain the world. | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The reference to whiteness (masculine) and redness (feminine) echoes fundamental kabbalistic color symbolism from early mystical texts, where white represents mercy/male and red represents judgment/female.

[i] The letter Mem here is an abbreviation for Malkhut, the tenth and lowest sefirah, which represents the divine feminine and is associated with judgment in Kabbalistic thought.

[ii] In Kabbalah, 'the point of Zion' represents a cosmic focal point where divine forces converge and balance, rather than just the geographical Jerusalem.

15 הנקבה שהם אותיות מקוה כי
סוד חמשה נקודות דהיינו סוד
חמש גבורות[i] חמשה אשות בסוד
אשה הנכנסת במים במי מקוה
העליונים הממתקים הדינים
20 וסודם הם מ׳ סאה[ii] י׳ היא
נקודה אמצעית ומ׳ סאה לד׳
צדדין הם סוד מים ודאי הם מצד
הבינה הנקרא מים דהיינו חמשים
בכלל הנקודה האמצעית שהיא
25 במל׳ ומיד היא מאירה הארה
גדולה ואבריה מתקנים תקון
גדול והוא משבח אותה בתקוניה
וויופי אבריה וא״ס מאיר ע״י
כתר דרך החכמה ע״י התפשטות
30 הדעת בסוד היסוד המעורר
אל הגן דהיינו סוד הפעולות
הספירות הנקביות והמתפלל
יכוין לעורר סוד רוח החיים
שהם ד׳ הנהגות הויה מצד הבינה
35 או י׳ הנהגות דהויה במלוי
אלפין מצד החכמה שאלו הם
חיים משולחים בתוך הספירות
להנהגתם בסוד אדם כי יקריב
וזהו סוד אני ישנה ולבי ער
40 דהיינו התעוררות החיים ממונה
עליה להנהיגה והבחינה תחתונה
שהיא אולת אהבה פי׳ יסורין
של אהבה מתראה לה ת״ת מצד
החסד ואפי׳ בקור בעלמא
45 מקל חוליה אחת מס׳ בחוליה.
בסוד ו״ק[iii] והבחינה עליונה

"mikveh."[A] The mystery of the five points—that is, the five powers of Gevurah, the five fires—exists in the concept of "woman" entering the waters[B] of the supernal mikveh that sweeten judgments. 15R

Their secret is forty se'ah: the Yod represents the central point, and forty se'ah in four directions[1] represent the mystery of waters, which come from Binah, called "waters"—that is, fifty in total, including the central point which is in Malkhut. Immediately she shines with great illumination, her limbs being perfectly rectified, and He praises her for her rectifications and the beauty of her limbs. The Infinite Light (Ein Sof) shines through Keter via the path of Chokhmah, through the expansion of Da'at in the mystery of Yesod, which awakens the Garden—namely, the mystery of feminine sefirot operations. 20R 25R 30R

The one who prays should intend to awaken the mystery of the spirit of life, which consists of either the four manifestations of the divine name from Binah, or the ten manifestations of the divine name spelled with Alefs from Chokhmah, for these are the lives dispatched within the sefirot to govern them, in the mystery of "when a person offers a sacrifice." This is the secret of "I sleep but my heart is awake"—meaning the awakening of life appointed over her to guide her. 35R 40R

The lower aspect, which is "foolishness of love" (meaning afflictions of love), appears to her as Tiferet from the side of Chesed, and even the slightest visitation alleviates her sickness, reducing one part out of sixty of her illness.[2] This operates through the mystery of the six extremities. And when the higher 45R

[A] Or: "and the waters of supernal mercies purify the stature of the feminine, which are the letters of "mikveh."" — This translation more literally follows the Hebrew word order and conveys that the letters themselves constitute 'mikveh' rather than merely corresponding to it.

[B] Or: "in the mystery of a woman immersing in water" — The term 'sod' literally means 'secret' or 'mystery' rather than 'concept,' and 'immersing' more specifically captures the ritual action implied than 'entering.'

[1] This cosmological arrangement (40 measures in four directions plus a central point) creates a structure corresponding to the 50 Gates of Understanding associated with Binah, illustrating how ritual requirements often reflect higher metaphysical structures in Kabbalah.

[2] The ratio of 1:60 is significant in Jewish law as the minimum proportion that renders something nullified (batel). Here it's applied mystically to the alleviation of suffering.

[i] The 'five Gevurot' (powers of judgment) correspond to the five final letters in Hebrew (מנצפ״ך) and represent different aspects of divine restriction necessary for creation.

[ii] Forty se'ah is the minimum amount of water required for a valid mikveh (ritual bath) according to Jewish law. Here it's being interpreted kabbalistically as representing cosmic structures.

[iii] The abbreviation ו״ק (Vav Ketzavot) refers to the 'six extremities' or directions (north, south, east, west, up, down), which correspond to the six lower sefirot from Chesed to Yesod.

שמתראה עליה אור החסד בזה מקל מאותה בחינה שהיא א׳ מס׳ בחינותיה הדין מעליה דכד עיינין תתאין מסתכלאן בעינא דאשגחותא נהירין. כי אברהם כח החסד בא בימים עליונים סוד ג׳ עליונות ונכללו בו והוא בהם וזה סוד קריבת ימיהם של צדיקים להתעלם בתמימות המיתה העליונה שהיא הצנע בקדש. וכל הקדמות אלו באו מכוונים בסדר תפלת חולים הן בג׳ מזמורים שלפניה הן בסדר התפלה והפסוקים הנמשכים אחריה. כשתדקדק בפנימיות אמריה כי נעמו: [i]

aspect of the light of Chesed appears to her, it alleviates from that aspect, which is one of her sixty aspects, removing judgment from her, for when the lower eyes gaze upon the eye of providence, they shine. For Abraham, the power of Chesed, "advanced in days" into the higher realms—the mystery of the three supreme attributes—and they were included in him, and he in them. This is the secret of the proximity of the days of the righteous, who delight in the perfection of the supernal death, which is concealed in holiness.

All these principles are aligned in the order of the prayer for the sick, both in the three psalms that precede it and in the order of the prayer and verses that follow it. When you examine the inner dimensions of its words, you will find them pleasant.

פרק ט״ו

Chapter 15

אמירת הוידוי לחולה הרבה פעמים מקל מעליו החולי יען שבזה ממתק כחות הדינים שעליו שלהיות שמדת הדין מתוחה עליו מאמת חטאיו שאין יסורין בלא עון צריך לזבוח עצמו לפייס מדת הדין בשבירת לבו ורוחו בקרבו כי זבח זה הוא למדת הדין כדכתיב זבחי אלהים רוח נשברה[ii] וכן כתיב גם עתה נאום ה׳ שובו עדי בכל לבבכם

Reciting confession (vidui) for the sick person often alleviates their illness because it sweetens the forces of judgment affecting them.[1] Since the attribute of judgment is extended over them due to their sins—for there is no suffering without sin—they must sacrifice themselves to appease the attribute of judgment by breaking their heart and spirit within them. This sacrifice is for the attribute of judgment, as it is written, "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit" (Psalms 51:19), and it is also written, "Even now, declares the LORD, return to Me with all your heart,

[1] The Hebrew term 'ממתק כחות הדינים' refers to the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgments,' which involves transforming harsh divine judgments into mercy through specific spiritual actions. This is not merely alleviating suffering but transforming its spiritual source.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, 'Siftei Renanot,' Chapter 3 — This passage develops ideas introduced earlier in the text about how the feminine aspects of divinity (Malkhut) can be elevated and purified through proper spiritual practice, particularly through the unification of masculine and feminine divine attributes. | Cf. Zohar, Parshat Pinchas, 220a — This passage draws directly on Zoharic conceptions of how harsh judgments are transformed through the 'waters' of divine mercy, using the metaphor of ritual immersion (mikveh) to describe this cosmic process. | Cf. Song of Songs 5:2 — The author interprets this verse kabbalistically as referring to Malkhut (the Divine Feminine) being guided by higher spiritual forces even when appearing dormant, reinforcing the text's theme of the relationship between higher and lower divine realms. | Cf. Genesis 24:1 — The text reinterprets the biblical description of Abraham as 'advanced in days' (בא בימים) in kabbalistic terms, suggesting that Abraham (representing the divine attribute of Chesed/Kindness) has access to higher spiritual realms (the 'upper days'). | Cf. Sefer Yetzirah — The text employs the concept of the six extremities or directions (״וק—an abbreviation for קצוות ו) from early Jewish mystical cosmology, representing the six lower sefirot that structure manifest reality.

[ii] This quote from Psalms 51:19 establishes a fundamental connection between confession, brokenness of heart, and spiritual sacrifice. The text uses this verse to show that the broken spirit resulting from sincere confession serves as a sacrifice to God, particularly appeasing the attribute of divine judgment.

בצום ובכי ומספד ובאמירת
הודוי נשבר לבו בקרבו ועוד
כי באמרם לו שיתן דעתו על
15 ענייניו אם הלוה או הפקיד אצל
אחרים או אחרים הלוו לו או
הפקידו אצלו ובזה מתקן מה
שבינו לבין חבירו והודוי מה
שבינו לבין המקום כדאמרו
20 בזהר בסוד הודוי שבתפלה ובזה
עושה נייחא לרוגז מדת הדין
ובזה מקל מעליו חוליו. ועוד
זוהמת ומים שופכים המתמצים
למטה באמירת הודוי הוא
25 חלק החצונים[i] שמחלק ס״מ
העונות החם על כחות חוליו
ונוטל לחלקו השופכין ההן
ועוד שבוידוי מסיר מעליו כל
קטיגור ואין מתעסק בדינו אלא
30 הקב״ה[ii] ואם תזכור או כי תשית
לבך אל מה שכתבתי בהערה
במעירי שחר בסוד התשובה
והודוי ולמה תקנוהו באלפא
ביתא תדע נאמנה שבאמירת
35 הודוי בכוונה מעורר הרחמים
העליונים מרישא איוורא
ומי״ג תקוני דיקנא[iii] הרוחצים

with fasting, weeping, and mourning"[1] (Joel 2:12).

When reciting the confession, one's heart is broken within, and furthermore, when they advise the sick person to consider their affairs—whether they 15R
have loaned or deposited items with others, or others have loaned to or deposited with them—this rectifies matters between the person and their fellow.[2] The confession itself rectifies matters between the person and God, as explained in the Zohar regarding 20R
the mystery of confession in prayer. This brings relief to the wrath of the attribute of judgment and thereby alleviates the person's illness. Moreover, the impurity and "poured waters" that are extracted below through the recitation of confession become 25R
the portion of the external forces. Samael distributes these sins among the forces causing the illness and takes these "pourings" as his share.[A] Additionally, through confession, one removes all accusers, so that only the Holy One, blessed be He, deals with their 30R
judgment.

If you recall or set your heart to what I wrote in the note in my "Illuminators of Dawn"[3] regarding the mystery of repentance and confession, and why the Sages established it in alphabetical order, you 35R
will surely know that reciting the confession with proper intention awakens the supernal mercies from

[A] Or: "Furthermore, the impurity and effluent waters that are extracted downward through confession become the portion of the external forces, as Samael distributes those sins among the forces causing illness and takes those effluents as his share." — This alternate translation uses 'effluent waters' rather than 'poured waters' to better capture the sense of impurities being extracted and flowing downward. It also simplifies some of the phrasing while maintaining the meaning.

[1] The text quotes Joel 2:12 to establish that true repentance requires both internal contrition (broken heart) and external expressions (fasting, weeping, mourning). This supports the emphasis on tears during confession.

[2] The text distinguishes between two types of rectification: between the person and other people (through addressing financial and material obligations), and between the person and God (through confession). This follows the rabbinic categorization of sins requiring different forms of atonement.

[3] This refers to another work by the author, Aaron Berechia of Modena, titled 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illuminators of Dawn), which apparently included explanations about confession and repentance.

[i] This striking metaphor describes confession as extracting spiritual impurity (zohamah) from the person in the form of 'poured waters' that are then claimed by external forces (chitzonim). This reflects the kabbalistic concept that confession not only acknowledges sin but physically removes it from the person.

[ii] This reflects the theological concept that sincere confession removes spiritual prosecutors/accusers (kategor), leaving only God to judge the person directly. This is considered a favorable outcome since divine mercy can then operate without opposition from negative spiritual forces.

[iii] These are advanced kabbalistic concepts referring to the 'White Head' (associated with Keter/Crown, the highest divine emanation) and the 'Thirteen Rectifications of the Holy Beard' (associated with the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy from Exodus 34:6-7). The text claims that proper confession activates these highest sources of divine mercy.

ומעבירים הדין מעליו בכמה
מיני סליחה וכפרה אשר בהם
40 כפי העת והצורך והשעה והיודע
סוד הדמעות[i] ידע ויבין טעם
למה רוב החולים המורידים
דמעות בודויהם הם נכתבים
לחיים וע״ש מזה ומה טוב
45 שלפחות אותו שמוודה החולה
שידע טעם הדבר כי גם ברכות
יעטה מורה זה אל החולה ובני
רשף יגביהו מעליו ואולי גם
לזה כוונו קדמונינו והנהיגו
50 ליאמר על ידי סרסור מלבד
הטעמים שכתבנו בזה במאמר
ראשון ובפרט כשיאמר בעת
שליטת החסד כאשר הוכחתי
במאמר ראשון פרק י׳. ועוד
55 נודע כי ההתעוררות העולה
מהצדיקים הוא מכניע היצר
הרע וחרטת העבירות ומעשה
הטוב שהוא סוד התשובה שהוא
פרטים על כל חטא וזהו סוד
60 עבירות הנעשות בזכיות לשב
מאהבה[ii] ובזה מתמתק הגבורה
והשכינה מתעלים בסוד קומה
שלמטה בתגבורת החסדים
והכנעת הדינים ומשם דבקה
65 בבינה שהיא נועם ה׳. וכמו
שהשוחט עולה צריך שתהיה

the White Head and from the Thirteen Rectifications of the Holy Beard,[1] which wash away and remove judgment through various forms of forgiveness and atonement according to the time, need, and hour. 40R

One who knows the mystery of tears will understand why most sick people who shed tears during their confessions are inscribed for life—see there for more on this. How good it would be if at least the person who guides the sick person in confession would know the reason for this, as the guide also brings blessings upon the sick person, and "the sons of the flame" (harmful forces) are lifted from them. Perhaps our ancestors also intended this when they instituted that confession be recited through an intermediary, besides the reasons we wrote about in the first discourse, particularly when recited during the time when the attribute of Loving-kindness (Chesed) dominates, as I proved in chapter 10 of the first discourse. 45R 50R 55R

It is also known that the spiritual awakening that arises from the righteous subdues the evil inclination, creates remorse for transgressions, and produces good deeds, which is the essence of repentance—addressing each sin in detail.[A] This is the mystery of how transgressions are transformed into merits for one who repents out of love.[2] Through this, the attribute of Strength (Gevurah) is sweetened, and the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) is elevated in the mystery of the Lower Structure[B3] through the intensification of kindnesses 60R 65R

[A] Or: "It is also known that the awakening that rises from the righteous ones subdues the evil inclination, brings remorse for transgressions, and [inspires] good deeds, which is the secret of repentance—detailing each sin individually." — This alternative more literally translates 'סוד התשובה' as 'secret of repentance' rather than 'essence of repentance,' preserving the mystical connotation of the original. It also more directly renders the Hebrew structure regarding the individual accounting of sins.

[B] Or: "through the mystery of the Lower Stature with the strengthening of mercies and the

[1] These are technical kabbalistic terms referring to the highest sources of divine mercy in the sefirotic system. The 'White Head' refers to Atik Yomin (Ancient of Days), and the 'Thirteen Rectifications of the Beard' correspond to the thirteen channels through which divine mercy flows into creation.

[2] This references the Talmudic concept (Yoma 86b) that repentance motivated by love of God (rather than fear of punishment) has the power to transform past sins into merits. The author integrates this rabbinic concept into his kabbalistic framework.

[3] The text describes a complex kabbalistic process where confession and repentance elevate the

[i] The 'mystery of tears' refers to the kabbalistic understanding that tears have special spiritual power, particularly in breaking divine decrees. This connection between physical tears and spiritual outcomes is a recurring theme in Jewish mystical literature.

[ii] This references the Talmudic concept (Yoma 86b) that one who repents out of love (rather than fear) has their sins transformed into merits. The text integrates this rabbinic idea into its kabbalistic framework of cosmic transformation.

מחשבתו לשם ששה דברים[i] לשם
הזבח לשם זובח ושהזבח
להקב״ה ושיקטירו לאישים
ושהקטרתו לריח ושהריח זה
נחת רוח לפני ה׳. כדרך הזה
לב אדם יחשוב דרכו סמוך לעת
פקידת רוחו ביד ה׳ ועל כן
טוב להזכיר עליו קצת מפסוקי
שחיטת העולה והחטאת. יראה
לי שטוב לחולה להרגיל עצמו
ובפרט אם הוא מסוכן חס ושלום
סדר הודוי שהיה אומר המביא
קרבן בעת שהיה סומך ידו על
ראשו שהוא חטאתי עויתי פשעתי
ועשיתי כך וכך והנה עתה חזרתי
בתשובה לפניך ויסורי גופי
יהיו כפרת נפשי ומרוק אותם
ברחמיך הרבים אך לא על ידי
יסורים והטוב בעיניך עשה.
וזהו ודוי הסומך אשר הביאו
הרמב״ם בפרק ב׳ מהלכות
מעשה הקרבנות:[ii]

and the subjugation of judgments, and from there it cleaves to Understanding (Binah), which is "the pleasantness of the LORD."[A]

Just as one who slaughters a burnt offering must have six intentions: for the sake of the sacrifice, for the sake of the one who sacrifices, that the sacrifice is for the Holy One, blessed be He, that it will be offered to the fires, that its offering is for a pleasing scent, and that this scent is a satisfaction before the LORD—in this manner should a person's heart contemplate its path as the time approaches for their spirit to be entrusted to the hand of the LORD. Therefore, it is good to recite for them some verses about the slaughtering of burnt offerings and sin offerings. 70R 75R 80R

It seems to me that it is beneficial for the sick person to accustom themselves, especially if they are in danger, God forbid, to the order of confession that was recited by one bringing a sacrifice when placing their hand upon its head: "I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled, and I have done such and such. Now I have returned in repentance before You. May the sufferings of my body be an atonement 85R

subjugation of judgments, and from there it adheres to Binah, which is "the pleasantness of the LORD."" — This alternative renders 'קומה שלמטה' as 'Lower Stature' rather than 'Lower Structure,' which may better reflect the kabbalistic concept of divine anthropomorphism. It also uses 'mercies' for 'חסדים' and 'adheres' for 'דבקה,' which are slightly more literal translations.

[A] Or: "through the mystery of the Lower Stature with the strengthening of mercies and the subjugation of judgments, and from there it adheres to Binah, which is "the pleasantness of the LORD."" — This alternative renders 'קומה שלמטה' as 'Lower Stature' rather than 'Lower Structure,' which may better reflect the kabbalistic concept of divine anthropomorphism. It also uses 'mercies' for 'חסדים' and 'adheres' for 'דבקה,' which are slightly more literal translations.

Divine Presence (Shekhinah) by intensifying divine kindness and subjugating judgment. This reflects the author's view that human spiritual actions have cosmic effects on divine attributes.

[i] The six intentions required when slaughtering a sacrifice are drawn from the Mishnah (Zevachim 4:6). The text applies this Temple ritual framework to the deathbed confession, creating a parallel between physical sacrifice and spiritual surrender.

[ii] Cf. Psalms 51:19 — This verse is cited to establish the connection between confession, brokenness of heart, and spiritual sacrifice. It provides biblical authority for the concept that confession with a broken spirit serves as a form of sacrifice acceptable to God. | Cf. Joel 2:12 — This verse is used to establish that true repentance requires wholehearted return to God with external signs of contrition. | Cf. Zohar — The text refers to Zoharic teachings about confession's mystical function in prayer, indicating that confession operates on multiple levels—not just as a personal acknowledgment of sin but as a cosmic process affecting divine attributes. | Cf. The White Head (reisha hivra) — This references the kabbalistic concept of Atik Yomin/Ancient of Days, representing the highest level of divine mercy. The passage suggests that proper confession activates this supreme source of compassion. | Cf. Thirteen Rectifications of the Holy Beard — These represent the thirteen channels of divine mercy in Kabbalistic thought, corresponding to the Thirteen Attributes of Mercy in Exodus 34:6-7. The passage teaches that confession activates these channels of forgiveness. | Cf. Maimonides, Laws of Sacrificial Procedures, Chapter 2 — The author cites Maimonides as an authoritative source for the traditional confession formula used when bringing sacrifices, drawing a parallel between Temple sacrifice and the sick person's confession. | Cf. Me'irei Shachar

for my soul, and may You purify them through Your abundant mercies, but not through sufferings, and do what is good in Your eyes." This is the confession of the one who leans [on the sacrifice], as brought by Maimonides in chapter 2 of the Laws of Sacrificial Procedures. 90R 95R

פרק ט״ז

Chapter 16

שבטי יה אשר הם עדות לישראל ביניהם אמרו אבל אשמים אנחנו על אחינו וגומר למדנו בזה להתוודות בעת צרה מפני שהצרה בודוי נאותה להמשיך הדין למטה ולמתק המדה העליונה שאינה מאירה מחמת החטא ובודוי העון עובר והיחוד הוה.[i] ונמצא בדברי החכם כי עקר שבירת הקליפות הוא על ידי הודוי ולכן כתיב כי יחטא ואשם והתודה ובזה פורש החצוני מן הקדושה בסוד מים אחרונים ושפך הדשן והמותר לשעיר המשתלח[ii] ובן בכל יום הכהן תורם תרומת הדשן תחלה קודם כל תקון לא פחות מקומץ כי בלילה ניתן להם

The tribes of the LORD, which are a testimony to Israel,[1] said among themselves, "But we are guilty concerning our brother," etc. From this we learn to confess in times of trouble because confession is appropriate during distress to draw judgment downward and to sweeten the supernal attribute[2] which does not shine due to sin. Through confession, the iniquity passes away and unification occurs. It is found in the words of the Sage that the essential breaking of the shells[A] (negative forces) is accomplished through confession, and therefore it is written, "When he sins and becomes guilty, he shall confess." Through this, the external force separates from holiness—this is the mystery of the "final waters"[3] (hand washing after meals), the removal of ashes, and the portion sent to the scapegoat. 5R 10R 15R

Similarly, each day the priest would remove a portion of ashes first, before any other ritual, no

[A] Or: "the primary shattering of the kelipot" — The term 'kelipot' is a technical kabbalistic term referring to negative spiritual forces or 'husks' that conceal divinity. While 'shells' is accurate, keeping the technical term 'kelipot' might be preferable in a scholarly translation focused on kabbalistic concepts.

[1] This refers to Genesis 42:21, where Joseph's brothers admit their guilt regarding their treatment of Joseph. The author uses this as a biblical precedent for confession during times of distress.

[2] These are technical kabbalistic concepts. 'Drawing judgment downward' means bringing divine severity into the lower worlds where it can be transformed. 'Sweetening' (mituk) refers to transforming harsh judgment into mercy through ritual actions.

[3] Mayim achronim refers to the ritual hand washing performed after meals, before the grace after meals. In kabbalistic thought, it serves to remove the 'portion' that belongs to the forces of impurity, similar to confession removing sin.

(Illuminators of Dawn) — The author refers to his own work 'Me'irei Shachar' which apparently contains additional explanations about confession and repentance. This indicates the author's intellectual production and his integration of this current text with his broader corpus.

[i] This phrase encapsulates a key kabbalistic understanding of confession: it not only removes sin but actively creates divine unification (yichud), connecting lower and higher worlds. The term 'yichud' specifically refers to the unification of divine masculine and feminine principles (YHVH and Shekhinah).

[ii] The author creates a parallel between confession and three Temple/ritual practices: mayim achronim (final water washing after meals), removal of ashes, and the scapegoat ritual. All three involve removing impurity or excess from sacred contexts, metaphorically representing how confession separates negative spiritual forces from holiness.

חלק מקומץ עליון במקום
אחיזתם ועתה מסיר אחיזתם
דינים אלו מהמזבח אשר לפני
ה׳ אותם שאינם בכלל השלום
וההכרעה לכן היה לובש בגדים
פחותים בעבודה זאת[i] ומי שזכה
בתרומת הדשן היה זוכה לתקן
המערכה ושני גזירי עצים כיון
שזכה לתקנה מדיניה הפגומים
היה עולה שלשה מדרגות
ודוגמא לעבודה הזאת היה
הדשן שצוברים בתפוח ומשם
מוצאים אותו חוץ לירושלים
במקום ששורפין פרים הנשרפים
וגם עבודה זו היתה בבגדים
פחותים והודוי שהיה נאמר
על הקרבן בכח הסמיכה בכל
כחו עליו בזה היה לבוש נשמת
החוטא נקרב שכן פני אדם
מתלבש בשאר הפנים[ii] ולכן
קבלת הדם להקריב על גבי
המזבח. ומשם ואילך היה על ידי
הכהן שכן מיכאל עומד ומקריב
נשמות הצדיקים.[iii] ובלבד
מה שהוכחנו בשפה ברורה
במאמר ראשון פרק י״ב וט״ו
כי טוב לחולה להתודות בבקר.
עוד יש ראיה לזה במכילתא
דאמרי׳ שם. מלמד שתפלתן
של צדיקים נשמעת בבקר בקרו
של אברהם בקרו של יעקב
בקרו של משה בקרו של יהושע
וכו׳ והובא בילקוט נבואים
ברמז י״ג על פסוק היה זרועם

less than a handful, because during the night they (external forces) are given a portion from the supernal handful at their point of attachment. Now he removes the attachment of these judgments from the altar before the LORD—those that are not included in peace and balance. Therefore, he would wear lesser garments[A] for this service. And whoever merited the removal of ashes would also merit arranging the altar and the two pieces of wood. Since he merited to repair it from its damaged judgments, he would ascend three steps.

A parallel to this service was the ashes accumulated on the "apple" (of the altar),[1] which were then taken outside Jerusalem to the place where the burned bulls were burned. This service too was performed in lesser garments. The confession that was recited over the sacrifice through forceful leaning with all one's strength—through this the soul of the sinner was clothed and brought near, just as the human face (of the divine chariot) clothes itself in the other faces. Therefore, the blood was received to be offered upon the altar, and from that point forward it was performed by the priest, just as Michael stands and offers the souls of the righteous.

We have already proven clearly in the first discourse, chapters 12 and 15, that it is good for the sick person to confess in the morning. There is further evidence for this in the Mekhilta, where it says: "This teaches that the prayers of the righteous are heard in the morning—the morning of Abraham, the morning of Jacob, the morning of Moses, the morning of Joshua," etc. This is cited in Yalkut Nevi'im, hint 13, on the verse "Be their arm every morning," and in the Pesikta it is interpreted regarding those

[A] Or: "wear worn garments" — The term might refer specifically to worn or older garments rather than garments of lesser quality or importance. This distinction matters in the ritual context of the Temple service.

[1] The 'apple' (tapuach) refers to a mound at the center of the altar where ashes would accumulate. This Temple ritual is presented as a model for the spiritual mechanics of confession.

[i] In the Temple service, the priest would wear simpler garments for the removal of ashes, symbolizing engagement with the less spiritually elevated aspects of the service. This parallels the spiritual mechanics of confession, which deals with the 'lower' aspects of existence (sin and impurity) in order to elevate them.

[ii] This references Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot (Merkavah), where the human face represents the highest aspect that encompasses the other faces (lion, ox, eagle). Similarly, in the confession ritual, the human soul encompasses and elevates all aspects of creation affected by sin.

[iii] This refers to the rabbinic tradition that the angel Michael serves as the heavenly High Priest who offers the souls of the righteous on the celestial altar. This creates a parallel between earthly confession and heavenly atonement.

לבקרים ובפסיקתא פירשוהו
על אותם שמשלימים בכל בקר
ובקר לבקש רחמים על הישועה
ונתאבלו על ציון כאשר הובא
בילקוט ירמיהו רמז שס״ד:
וכבר הערנו לב הנרדמים קרא
נא אחי מזה בסוף מעירי שחר
שלנו והעידו גורי האר״י עליו
שהיה אומר בלילי אשמורות עם
הצבור הכל מלה במלה והזהירו
שם מאד לומר סדר חורבן הבית
בכל לילה קודם הלימוד ואמרו
שכן. היה עושה הוא בכונה
גדולה והיה בוכה בו בכל
לילה. וכל הדברים והמזמורים
שקבלנו מפי מגידי אמת וקצת
מהם ראינו בקונטרסיו הגם
שבא לידנו הלכתא בלא טעמא
הכל הכללנו אותם בדברינו
שם ועשינו להם סמוכות כאשר
שת אלהים בפינו. ונמצא כתוב
בשמו שראוי לאדם לכוין אחר
חצות בפסוק פקח עיניך וראה
שוממותינו ולכוין בתיבת פקח
בגימטרא שם הו״יה אהיה במלוי
אלפין שהוא קפ״ח[i] הרי שניהם
בגימטריא פקח ותאיר בהם מן
שם אהיה דיודין בגימטריא עיניך
קס״א וזה מועיל מאד אל האדם.
ובין המצרים טוב להתאבל
על החרבן אחר חצות ולבכות
כמו חצי שעה ויועיל לנפש.
עוד בילקוט ברמז שס״ה נראה
שהמתים מדיינים זה עם זה אחר
מיתתן לפני שופט צדק[ii] כאשר

who complete their prayers every morning seeking mercy for salvation, and who mourned for Zion, as is brought in Yalkut Jeremiah, hint 364. 55R

We have already awakened the hearts of those who slumber—please read, my brother, from the end of our "Me'irei Shachar"[1] (Dawn Illuminators). The disciples of the ARI testified about him that he would recite the midnight vigils with the 60R congregation, word for word, and they emphasized there the importance of reciting the order of the destruction of the Temple every nig[2]ht before study. They said that he did this with great intention and would weep over it every night. All the words and 65R psalms that we received from reliable sources, some of which we saw in his pamphlets—even though the laws came to us without their reasons—we have included all of them in our words there and provided support for them as God placed in our mouths. 70R

It is found written in his name that it is proper for a person to focus after midnight on the verse "Open Your eyes and see our desolations," and to concentrate on the word "pakach" (open), which has the numerical value of the divine names YHVH and Ehyeh 75R with the alef filling,[3] which is 188—both together equal the numerical value of "pakach." And "illuminate them" with the divine name Ehyeh with the yod filling, which has the numerical value of "einekha" (Your eyes), 161. This is very beneficial for a person. 80R And during the Three Weeks[4] (between the 17th of Tammuz and the 9th of Av), it is good to mourn over the destruction after midnight and to weep for about half an hour, which will benefit the soul.

Further, in Yalkut, hint 365, it appears that the 85R dead argue with each other after their death before the Righteous Judge, as we proved in the second

[1] This appears to be a prayer collection or treatise composed by the author, Aaron Berechia of Modena, containing liturgical material for dawn prayers, including confessional prayers.

[2] This refers to the practice of Tikkun Chatzot, the midnight lamentation over the destruction of the Temple, which was emphasized in Lurianic Kabbalah as a significant spiritual practice.

[3] This refers to spelling divine names with specific letter 'fillings' (milui), a kabbalistic practice that affects the name's numerical value and spiritual potency. 'Alef filling' means using the letter alef in the expanded spelling of the divine name.

[4] The period between the 17th of Tammuz and the 9th of Av, commemorating the events leading to the destruction of both Temples. This is a time of mourning in the Jewish calendar.

[i] This illustrates the kabbalistic practice of using gematria (numerical values of Hebrew letters) to create correspondences between words and divine names. The numerical value of the word 'pakach' (open) is equated with the combined value of two divine names written with specific letter fillings, creating a spiritual mechanism for 'opening' divine mercy.

[ii] This reflects the Jewish belief that judgment continues after death and that souls may have

הוכחנו במאמר שני כי כתוב
שם שאמר אבנר לישראל אחר
שתפסו ליואב בידיו שהיו ישראל
מפייסים לפניו שלא יהרוג אותו
אחר שהכהו וכמת היה תחת ידו
מכח גבורתו כדאמרי׳ אמר רבי
יוסי נוח לכל אדם לזוז כותל
של שש מאות אמות מלזוז רגל
אחד של אבנר ואז אמר להם מה
אעשה שכבה את נרי. א״ל תדון
עמו לפני דיין האמת השליכו
אותו מידו ונפל זה חי וזה מת אם
בן לטובתו נתכוון דוד בצוותו
את שלמה בנו שלא ינקהו מן
המיתה פן חס ושלום יוריד את
שיבתו ביגון שאולה ליה עבד
ליה דלשקיל למטרפסיה בהאי
עלמא כנדרש אצלנו במקומו
והובא גם כן באגדת ירושלמי: [i]

discourse. For it is written there that Abner said to Israel after they seized Joab in his hands—as Israel was appeasing him not to kill Joab after he had struck him and Joab was like a dead man under his hand due to Abner's strength—as they said: Rabbi Yosi said, "It is easier for any man to move a wall of six hundred cubits than to move one foot of Abner." Then Abner said to them, "What shall I do, for he has extinguished my lamp."[1] They said to him, "You will judge him before the True Judge." They cast Joab from Abner's hand, and one fell alive and the other dead. If so, David intended for Joab's benefit when he commanded his son Solomon not to let Joab go unpunished from death, lest, God forbid, Joab bring his gray head down to Sheol in sorrow. Rather, he ensured that Joab would receive his portion in this world,[A] as we have explained in its place, and as is also brought in the Jerusalem Aggadah.

פרק י״ז

Chapter 17

אשרי אדם שאמונת עתו

Blessed is the person whose faith is in the Torah,

[A] Or: "he acted to ensure Joab would take his sustenance in this world" — This Aramaic phrase is challenging to translate precisely. 'Matrapsya' can refer to sustenance or livelihood, but in this context it may specifically refer to receiving punishment in this world rather than the next. Either translation conveys the general meaning, but the nuance differs slightly.

[1] This is both literal (referring to death, as the soul is compared to a lamp) and figurative (referring to legacy and reputation), conveying Abner's complaint that Joab had attempted to end both his life and his honor.

disputes that require divine adjudication. This understanding provides additional motivation for proper confession before death, as unresolved matters may continue into the afterlife.

[i] Cf. Genesis 42:21 — The author uses this biblical example to establish confession as a spiritually effective response to trouble. The brothers' confession during their distress in Egypt serves as a paradigm for the spiritual efficacy of confession during times of trouble. | Cf. Leviticus 5:5 — The author quotes this verse to establish the biblical basis for confession as a mechanism for separating negative forces from holiness. In the ritual context, confession is portrayed as an essential component that precedes physical atonement. | Cf. Zohar — The author alludes to Zoharic teachings about confession's power to break the kelipot (shells/husks), portraying confession as a mystical act that has cosmic significance beyond personal atonement, affecting the balance of forces in higher worlds. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First Discourse, Chapters 12 and 15 — The author refers to his earlier chapters which provide more detailed explanations about the importance of morning confession for the sick. This self-reference indicates the work's internal coherence and the author's intention to build upon earlier material rather than repeat it. | Cf. Mekhilta d'Rabbi Ishmael — The author cites this midrash to support his recommendation for morning confession, building on the tradition that the morning is especially auspicious for prayer, with biblical examples of morning prayers being answered. | Cf. 2 Samuel 3:27-38 — This reference to the biblical story of Abner and Joab is used to illustrate how judgment continues after death, suggesting that confession is important not only for this world but also for judgment in the next world. The author uses this to emphasize the cosmic significance of proper confession.

בתורה[i] וכמו שכתוב וחרפה
לא נשא על קרובו כי ישכב
בשלום וממרחק יובא לחמו
כדתניא דבי אליהו כיון שבא
אדם למקרא למשנה ומ״ט הם
זנין ומפרנסים ומכלכלים אותו
עד שעה שהוא נכנס לבית עולמו.
ועליו אמר הכתוב והיה אמונת
עתך וגו׳ ובילמדנו פ׳ תשא
כתוב כל העוסק בתורה פרנסתו
מן התורה ומתעשר ומצליח.
פוק חזי דברי הרמב״ם על זה
סוף הלכות שמיטה ויובל. גם
כן בילמדנו דף נ״ג ע״ב אשרי
המלמד עצמו תורה ונותן ממונו
ללמד עצמו ובניו תורה. וכתוב
שם בפרשה קדושים דף ס״ב כל
מצות וחסד שאדם עושה דיו
לשעה שנפשו יוצאה ממנו לכן
כתיב כל עמל האדם לפיהו. הנה
כי לעת מצא צריך בוונה ותפלה
ועיין בפי׳ משלי להחכם אלשיך
דרוש יפה ונעים על עסק התורה
בפ׳ הט אזנך ושמע דברי חכמים
ותחלתו בדף קי״ח ואיכות
התורה עצמה שעסק האדם
בעולם הזה היא תשוש עם נפשו
בגילה עצמית בדדרשו על פסוק
ותגל יולדתך כי השפע שלה
תחכים לעוסק בה כאלו ילדו
והיא באורה ושמחה עמו והזהיר
האר״י לכוין בכל מקום בהזכרת
שם הויה באותיות יה״ו לזעיר
ובה׳ אחרונה לנוקביה[ii] שכולל

as it is written, “He does not bear reproach against his relative, for he will lie down in peace and his bread will be brought from afar.” As taught in the school of Elijah: Once a person has studied Scripture, Mishnah, and the forty-nine aspects of Torah interpretation,[1] these sustain and nourish him until the time he enters his eternal home. Of such a person Scripture says, “Faith in your times will be...” And in the Yelamdeinu commentary on Parashat Ki Tisa, it states: “Whoever engages in Torah study receives his livelihood from the Torah itself, becoming wealthy and prosperous.” Go and see the words of Maimonides on this topic at the end of the Laws of the Sabbatical and Jubilee Years.[2] Similarly, in Yelamdeinu page 53b: “Fortunate is one who teaches himself Torah and provides his money to teach himself and his children Torah.” And it is written there in Parashat Kedoshim, page 62: “All the commandments and acts of kindness that a person performs are sufficient for the moment when his soul departs from him,” which is why Scripture states, “All the labor of a person is for his mouth.”

Indeed, at the time of finding[3] [death], one needs proper intention and prayer. Examine the commentary on Proverbs by the sage Alshekh—a beautiful and pleasant exposition on Torah study in the section “Incline your ear and listen to the words of the wise,” beginning on page 118. The quality of the Torah itself that a person studies in this world brings his soul to inherent joy, as they interpreted the verse “and your mother who bore you will rejoice,” for the divine flow of Torah enlightens those who engage with it as if the Torah itself had given birth to them, and the Torah radiates light and rejoices with them.

[1] The Hebrew ‘ומ״ט’ (ve-M”T) refers to the 49 (mem-tet = 40+9) methods or aspects of Torah interpretation in rabbinic tradition, symbolically connected to the 49 levels of understanding.

[2] This refers to Maimonides’ famous conclusion to Hilkhot Shemitah ve-Yovel, where he states that anyone who dedicates themselves to divine service will have their needs provided for, just as the Levites were supported while serving in the Temple.

[3] The Hebrew phrase ‘לעת מצא’ (le-et matza) is from Psalm 32:6, traditionally interpreted as referring to the time of death. The term carries the double meaning of ‘finding’ (as in finding one’s final destiny) and ‘going forth’ (departing from life).

[i] This opening references Isaiah 33:6, “faith in your times shall be a strength of salvation,” applying it to Torah study as providing spiritual sustenance at the time of death.

[ii] This refers to the kabbalistic teaching of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the ARI) about proper intention when pronouncing the divine name. The first three letters (YHV) correspond to Zeir Anpin (the Lesser Countenance), while the final letter (H) corresponds to Nukvah (the feminine aspect of divinity).

הכל ממעלה למטה וגם באמצע
שהם הוי״ה ואדנו״ת משולבים
בסוד הקריאה והכתיבה ולזה
יכוין בפסוק פותח את ידיך לשני
יודי״ן כנודע והוא גם כן הזהיר
על שאלת המזונות בכל יום
בשומע תפלה להורות שבוטח
בה׳ והיודע לחשב ברמז ההויות
וסמיכות הפסוקים בנקודותיהם
ר״ת וס״ת ותוכי תיבות ושאר
כוונות שבאו בשאלת מזונות
הערוך במעירי שחר ואומר
אותם בכל יום מובטחים אנו
ברחמי שמים שלא יבא לעולם
לידי חוסר מזונות וכל שכן אם
יאמרם במקהלו״ת בגימטריא
עשרה[i] והיה מרגלא בפומיה
של החכם הנזכר זצ״ל שעקר
כוונת קביעות התורה וההשגה
תלוי בכוונה הזאת היינו שיכוין
לקשר נפשו ולהדביקה בשרשה
על ידי התורה כדי להשלים
אילן החיים ואדם העליון
ולתקנו[ii] כי זה תכלית בריאת
האדם ותכלית עסקו בתורה
וכן היה אומר כי אין דבר מונע
ההשגה כמו העצבות[iii] והיה
מזרז ג״כ לתלמידיו שיסתכלו
חמיד בשמים כי בזה יוסיף להם
טהרה והיה מזהיר מאד על
כוונת ברכות הנהנין. וכתוב
בילמדנו סוף פרשת ברכה
הצדיקים מברכים על כל דבר
ודבר שאוכלים ושותים ושרואין
וששומעין ולא בחייהם בלבד
אלא אפילו במיתתן מברכים
ומודים לפני הקב״ה שנאמר
יעלזו חסידים בכבוד וגו׳

The ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria) cautioned[1] to concentrate, whenever mentioning the Divine Name, on the letters Y-H-V as representing Zeir Anpin (the Lesser Countenance) and on the final H as representing its feminine counterpart, thus encompassing everything from above to below. This also applies to the center, where YHVH and ADNY are interwoven in the mystery of reading and writing. One should have this intention when reciting the verse "You open Your hand," focusing on the two Yods, as is known. He also emphasized requesting sustenance daily in the "Hear our prayer" blessing, demonstrating trust in God. Those who know how to calculate the divine names through hints, the connections between verses with their vowel points, acronyms, final letters, interior letters, and other kavanot (mystical intentions) that appear in the request for sustenance arranged in "Me'irei Shachar" (Illuminators of Dawn) and recite them daily—we are assured by the mercies of Heaven that they will never experience lack of sustenance, especially if recited in "congregations" (numerically equivalent to ten).

It was a common saying of the aforementioned sage, of blessed memory, that the essential intention of establishing Torah study and spiritual attainment depends on this intention—namely, that one should intend to bind one's soul and attach it to its root through Torah study, in order to complete the Tree of Life and the Supernal Adam and rectify them. For this is the purpose of human creation and the ultimate goal of one's engagement with Torah. He would also say that nothing hinders spiritual attainment as much as sadness. He would encourage his students to gaze frequently at the heavens, as this increases their purity, and he was very particular about the proper intentions for blessings over enjoyment.

It is written in Yelamdeinu at the end of Parashat Berachah: "The righteous bless everything they eat,

[1] Rabbi Isaac Luria (1534-1572), known as the ARI (the Lion), was the preeminent kabbalist of Safed whose teachings revolutionized Jewish mysticism. His influence is evident throughout Ma'avar Yabok, particularly in its approach to kavvanot (mystical intentions) during prayer.

[i] The Hebrew word 'mak'helot' (congregations) has the numerical value of 10, which corresponds to a minyan, the quorum required for communal prayer.

[ii] This describes the kabbalistic purpose of Torah study: to bind one's soul to its divine source, thereby completing and rectifying the cosmic structures known as the 'Tree of Life' and the 'Supernal Adam.'

[iii] This reflects a core Hasidic principle (though predating Hasidism proper) that sadness is the greatest obstacle to spiritual attainment, while joy facilitates connection to the divine.

רוממות אל בגרונם וחרב
75 פיפיות בידם. והיה מזהיר
החכם גם כן לקום מפני שיבה
להיותו דוגמת דיוקן סבא קדישא
ודיקנא חיוורא. ואמרו במדרש
בשכר עוסקי תורה כאשר הובא
80 בילקוט ישעיה רמז רצ״ג כי
אין אדם יושב בישיבה של
מעלה אא״כ יושב בישיבה של
מטה.[i] ועוד שהבריות מרננים
אחריו ואומרים איש פלוני
85 כשר וחסיד ונאה להיות חכם
וכמו שהאדם עוסק בתורה
בעולם הזה כן מפלפל בישיבה
של מעלה כדאמרו בסוטה על
יהודה בדרשת פ׳ ידיו רב לו
90 לא הוה ידע למשקל ולמטרא
בשמעתתא וכו׳ לא הוה סלקא
ליה שמעתתא אליבא דהלכתא
וכו׳ וכן במדרש תנחומא פרשת
שמות כשם שנושאים ונותנים
95 בהלכה למטה כך נושאין ונותנים
בהלכה למעלה וראיה גם כן
ממעשה דרבה בר נחמני. על כי
יזהר האדם להודות על האמת
ואל יפלפל לקנתר חס ושלום כי
100 בפלפול שלא לשם שמים שפחה
תירש גברתה ומפרי מעשיו
ישביעוהו מרורים ואמרו שם פ׳
בא אריב״ל בג׳ מקומות מצינו
שהאדם משמיע למודו סמוך
105 למיתתו מנין שנאמר להודיעך
קושט דברי אמת להשיב אמרים
אמת לשולחך. וכן שלמה אמר
סוף דבר הכל נשמע וגומר רבי
תנחומא בר אבא אומר כיון שבא
110 להסתלק מלאכי השרת אומרים
תנו עוז לאלהים:[ii]

drink, see, and hear—not only in their lifetime but even in their death they bless and give thanks before the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is said, 'Let the pious exult in glory... The high praises of God in their throats and a double-edged sword in their hands.'" The sage would also instruct to rise before the elderly, as they exemplify the image of the Holy Elder and the White Beard. 75R 80R

They said in the Midrash regarding the reward for those who engage in Torah study, as brought in Yalkut Isaiah, hint 293: "No person sits in the heavenly academy unless he sits in an earthly academy." Furthermore, people speak admiringly of him, saying, "Such a person is upright, pious, and worthy of being a sage." Just as a person engages in Torah study in this world, so does he engage in dialectical analysis in the heavenly academy, as they said in Sotah regarding Judah, in the exposition of the verse "his hands shall contend for him": "He did not know how to weigh and give in discussions of legal traditions... his legal discussion did not ascend in accordance with the halakhah..." Similarly, in Midrash Tanchuma, Parashat Shemot: "Just as they discuss halakhah below, so do they discuss halakhah above," with further evidence from the story of Rabbah bar Nachmani. 85R 90R 95R

Therefore, a person should be careful to acknowledge the truth and not engage in pilpul (dialectical argumentation) to provoke, God forbid, for in pilpul not for the sake of Heaven, "the maidservant inherits her mistress,"[1] and from the fruit of his actions, he will be filled with bitterness. They said there in Parashat Bo: Rabbi Joshua ben Levi taught, "We find in three places that a person transmits his learning shortly before his death. From where do we know this? As it is said, 'To make known to you the truth of reliable words, so that you may give a true reply to those who sent you.' And thus Solomon said, 100R 105R 110R

[1] This metaphor refers to when dialectical argumentation (pilpul) becomes an end in itself rather than a means to truth, causing Torah study to lose its spiritual purpose. The 'maidservant' (inferior motivation) displaces the 'mistress' (authentic Torah understanding).

[i] This is a key theological concept in rabbinic Judaism that one's status in the heavenly academy (yeshiva shel ma'alah) depends on one's Torah study in the earthly academy (yeshiva shel matah).
[ii] Cf. The concept of proper kavvanot (intentions) during prayer — This passage connects to the fourth section of Ma'avar Yabok, which focuses on prayer as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings. Both emphasize that proper intention (kavvanah) during religious acts creates cosmic effects beyond the physical world. | Cf. Psalm 149:5-6 — The passage quotes 'Let the pious exult in glory... high praises of God in their throats and a double-edged sword in their hands' (Psalm

'The end of the matter, all has been heard...' Rabbi Tanchuma bar Abba says, 'When one is about to depart, the ministering angels say, "Give strength to God."'" 115R

פרק י״ח

כתוב במנהגי האר״י כי אין דבר מועיל להשגת האדם כמו ענין הטהרה והטבילה שיהיה האדם טהור בכל עת וכמה פעמים הזהרתי לחברי ותלמידי שירגילו עצמם ברחיצת ט׳ קבין לפחות בכל חדש בימים שאשתו פורשת ממנו עד כי תתקדש מטומאתה דכל אינון יומין זווגא עילאה מזדווג בהדיה דישתכח דכר ונוקבא כדאמרי׳ בזהר פ׳ בראשית וזה לפי שכל טומאה פוגמת בנפש שכמו שבהיות האדם נמשך אחר יצר הרע פוגם נפשו כן בהשליט עליו כח הטומא׳ קרוב אל החטא שהיצה״ר מתגבר בימינו וקדושה אינה שורה עליו לעוזרו ועל כן הטובל לקרייו ירגיש בנפשו תוספת קדושה וזהו טעם האוכלי׳ חוליהן בטהרה. וכבר כתבתי כוונת רחיצת ט׳ קבין ושעורה בדקדוק במאמר שני פרק כ״ה. עוד כתוב שם כי הוא היה נוהג לומר קודם שיכנס לבית המדרש תפלת ר׳ נחוניא בן הקנה הכתובה במשנה ומפורשת בגמ׳ ואח״כ היה אומר

Chapter 18

It is written in the customs of the ARI that nothing benefits a person's spiritual attainment like the matter of purity and immersion, that a person should be pure at all times. I have warned my colleagues and students many times to accustom themselves to 5R
washing with nine kav [of water] at least once each month, on the days when his wife separates from him until she becomes purified from her impurity. For during all those days, a supernal union joins with him so that male and female are found [together], 10R
as stated in the Zohar, Parashat Bereshit. This is because all impurity damages the soul,[A] for just as when a person is drawn after the evil inclination he damages his soul, so too when the power of impurity dominates him, he is close to sin, as the evil 15R
inclination strengthens at his right side, and holiness does not rest upon him to help him. Therefore, one who immerses after a seminal emission will feel an addition of holiness in his soul. This is the reason for those who eat their ordinary food in a state of 20R
ritual purity.[B]

I have already written about the intention for washing with nine kav and its precise measurement in the second discourse, chapter 25. It is further written there that he [the ARI] would customarily 25R
recite, before entering the study hall, the prayer of Rabbi Nechunya ben HaKanah that is written in the

[A] Or: "ritual impurity blemishes the soul" — The Hebrew term 'pegimah' often refers specifically to a 'blemish' or 'flaw' in kabbalistic contexts rather than general damage, and 'tumah' has the specific meaning of ritual impurity in Jewish law.

[B] Or: "those who consume their non-sacred food in a state of ritual purity" — The term 'chullin' specifically refers to non-sacred food (as opposed to terumah or other sacred foods), which provides more precision about the rabbinic practice being referenced.

149:5-6) to demonstrate that the righteous continue to praise God even after death, supporting the book's view that souls remain spiritually active beyond physical life. | Cf. Interweaving of divine names YHVH and ADNY — The passage's reference to interweaving the divine names YHVH and ADNY connects to the book's deathbed prayers, where these combined divine names create special protection for the departing soul. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 12:13 — The reference to Solomon's 'The end of the matter, all has been heard' (Ecclesiastes 12:13) supports the book's theme that final words before death carry special spiritual significance. | Cf. Proverbs 22:21 — The citation of 'To make known to you the truth of reliable words, so that you may give a true reply to those who sent you' (Proverbs 22:21) supports the book's emphasis on confession and truthful speech at the time of death.

פסוק כי ה׳ יתן חכמה מפיו
דעת ותבונה גל עיני ואביטה
וגו׳ וקבלתי כי פסוק יערוף
במטר לקחי תז״ל בט״ל אמרת״.
בשעירים עלי ד״שא וכרביבים
ע״לי עשב ופסוק צור תעודה
חתום תורה בלמודי ישר והפוך
ושלשה פעמים ברוך אתה ה׳
למדני חוקיך ופסוק בחוקותיך
אשתעשע לא אשכח דבריך
ומזמור שיר המעלות הנה ברכו
את ה׳ וגו׳ טוב לאומרם קודם
הלימוד. וכתוב בסדר עולם כי
אליהו כותב כל מעשה הדורות
כולם וכן אמרו במדרש רבה שעל
כל מצוה אליהו כותב והקב״ה
חותם. וגדול כח הדבור שנחשב
עקימת שפתים עתה כמעשה בזמן
המקדש וזה שבהיות בית המקדש
קיים שהיתה שכינה שורה בו
והיחוד בכל העולמות החוטא
אז היה גורם הפירוד במעשה
לכן צריך ליחד במעשה הקרבן
ואז אם אדם היה חייב חטאת
אפילו יעסוק כל ימיו בחטאת
ומעשהו בתורה שבכתב ושבע״פ
לא מפני זה יכופר נפש ההוא
אבל אחר חרבן הבית היחודים
עתה עולים בבחינתה המסתלקת
למעלה דהיינו הבחינה הנקרא
דבור עם המחשבה העליונה לכן
עסק התורה גורם תקון לעונו
וכל העוסק בתורת חטאת כאילו
הקריב חטאת וכו׳ כי האותיות
יעלו ויפעלו התעוררות למעלה
במציאות שהוא ע״י קול ודבור
שהם תפארת ומלכות ומחשבה
ורעותא דלבא שהם חכמה ובינה
י״ה על ו״ה ועקימת שפתים
משויא להו מעשה עם תנועת
הגוף קצת וכבר דברנו הזה
במאמר ראשון ובחלק מנחת
אחרן. אשרי המטהר רעיוניו
וגופו כי בזה משים בקרבו את
רוח קדשו ותמימי דרך ההולכים

Mishnah and explained in the Gemara. Afterward he would say the verse "For the LORD gives wisdom; from His mouth come knowledge and understanding" [Proverbs 2:6], "Uncover my eyes that I may behold..." [Psalm 119:18], etc.

I have received [a tradition] that it is good to recite before study the verse "May my teaching drop like rain, may my words flow like dew" [Deuteronomy 32:2], "Like showers on tender grass, like raindrops on the herb" [Deuteronomy 32:2], and the verse "Bind up the testimony, seal the teaching among My disciples" [Isaiah 8:16] both forward and backward, and [to recite] three times "Blessed are You, O LORD, teach me Your statutes" [Psalm 119:12], and the verse "In Your statutes I will delight; I will not forget Your word" [Psalm 119:16], and the psalm "A Song of Ascents: Behold, bless the LORD..." [Psalm 134:1], etc.

It is written in Seder Olam that Elijah writes all the deeds of the generations, and so they said in Midrash Rabbah that for every commandment, Elijah writes and the Holy One, blessed be He, seals. Great is the power of speech, for the movement of the lips is now considered like the actual deed was in the time of the Temple. For when the Temple was standing, with the Divine Presence dwelling in it and unity in all worlds, one who sinned then caused separation through [his] deed; therefore, one needed to unify through the deed of the sacrifice. Then, if a person was obligated to bring a sin-offering, even if he were to occupy himself all his days with [studying] the sin-offering and its procedures in the Written and Oral Torah, the soul would not be atoned for because of this. But after the destruction of the Temple, the unifications now ascend in its aspect that rises above, namely the aspect called "speech" with the supernal thought. Therefore, the study of Torah causes rectification for one's sin, and whoever engages in the laws of the sin-offering, it is as if he offered a sin-offering, etc.

For the letters ascend and effect an awakening above in reality, which is through voice and speech, which are Tiferet and Malkhut,[A] and through thought and the desire of the heart, which are Chokhmah and Binah—[represented by the letters]

[A] Or: "Tiferet and Malkhut (Beauty and Kingdom)" — Adding the English translations of these kabbalistic terms would be helpful for readers unfamiliar with the sefirot, though in a scholarly context the Hebrew terms alone might be sufficient.

בתורת ה׳ אפילו מלאך המות
אוהב אותם כדדרשו בסוף פ׳
אין מעמידין על פסוק עלמות
אהבוך:[i]

Yod-Hei over Vav-Hei[A]—and the movement of lips with some movement of the body renders it an [actual] de[B]ed. We have already discussed this in the first discourse and in the section Minchat Aharon.

Fortunate is one who purifies his thoughts and body, for through this he places within himself His holy spirit. And those of perfect way who walk in the Torah of the LORD, even the Angel of Death loves them, as they expounded at the end of the chapter "Ein Ma'amidin" on the verse "Therefore maidens love you" [Song of Songs 1:3].

פרק י״ט

Chapter 19

אם יסורי החולה הם מעין יסורין
של אהבה שאין בהם ביטול תפלה
ולבו יאמר לו כי ירבה תחנונים
לאלהים שישיבהו לאיתנו הנה
כבר העלינו במעירי שחר שלנו
בדף ר״י ואילך בקשות נאות
לחולה וגם שהם בלשון רבים
ישים אל לבו לבקש רחמים על
כל חולי עמו באהבה כי לעולם
לשתתף איניש נפשיה בהדי
צבורא וכל הצריך לאותו דבר
ומתפלל על חבירו הוא נענה
תחלה. פוק חזי עוד משם בדף
קצ״א ע״ב עד דף קצ״ה[ii] ושם

If the sick person's afflictions are like the "afflictions of love" which do not involve the cancellation of prayer, and his heart tells him to multiply supplications to God to restore him to health, we have already included in our "Me'irei Shachar" [Illuminators of Dawn] on page 210 and onwards appropriate prayers for the sick. Even though they are written in the plural form, one should direct one's heart to seek mercy for all the sick of the nation with love, for a person should always include himself with the community, and whoever needs something himself but prays for his fellow will be answered first. Go and see further there from page 191b to page 195, where there are certain supplications designed to be recited

[A] Or: "Yod-Hei (representing the upper sefirot) over Vav-Hei (representing the lower sefirot)" — This expanded translation explains the kabbalistic significance of these letter pairs as representing different aspects of the divine emanations, which provides important context for understanding the mystical concept being described.

[B] Or: "the articulation of the lips is considered equivalent to an action" — This is a Talmudic phrase with technical legal significance about verbal declarations being legally binding, so a more precise translation conveys the legal equivalence being established.

[i] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Bereshit — This reference establishes that marital separation doesn't mean spiritual separation—in fact, it can create a different type of spiritual union. This supports the ARI's instruction about ritual immersion during these periods. | Cf. Prayer of Rabbi Nechunya ben HaKanah — This prayer reflects the ARI's emphasis on proper spiritual preparation before Torah study, creating the right mindset and spiritual protection. | Cf. Seder Olam — The reference suggests that our actions have cosmic significance and are recorded in the heavenly realms, emphasizing the importance of proper spiritual conduct. | Cf. Minchat Aharon — This self-reference shows that Aaron Berechia of Modena addressed this topic of speech as a spiritual substitute for Temple offerings in multiple works, indicating its importance in his thought. | Cf. 'Therefore maidens love you' (Song of Songs 1:3) — This creative reading of the verse from Song of Songs supports the author's point that true Torah devotees are beloved even by the Angel of Death, emphasizing the protective power of Torah study and ritual purity.

[ii] The author is referring readers to specific pages in his own prayer collection, 'Me'irei Shachar,' demonstrating how this work serves as a practical complement to the more theoretical discussions in Ma'avar Yabok.

איזה סליחות שמכוונות להאמר ביום אשר תקדש עצמך בתענית של ערב ר״ח באשר כוונתי במאמר ד׳ בקרבן תענית וזה נוסף על סליחות אחרות והודוי המכוין ליום צום שהם מדף ק״פ עד דף קפ״ו. וכבר הרגלנום בסוד ישרים ועדה ביום התענית של המשמרת שלנו בס״ד כי ראוי לכל אדם להצטער בעת מעוט הלבנה.[i] אך מצאתי בדברי החכם שאין ראוי להסתכל בלקות הלבנה והראיה כי הכהן אינו אומר טמא לבית המנוגע שאינו נוהג אלא בארץ ישראל דוקא עד אחר שיצא מפתח הבית כי בלה שפרסה נדה אין ראוי שהשושבין יאמר כך בפניה. וזהו טעם בנגע נראה לי לא נגע[ii] כדי שלא להוציא דבה על ארץ ישראל בת מלך. כי נגע הוא מכתש סגירו שסוגר ומונע השפע נגד הארץ אשר ה׳ אלהיך דורש אותה תמיד. ואם תזכה ביום התענית לכוין מעשיך בסוד תקון עליון הנה מה טוב כי בבקר השכם ביום ההוא בהיותך לבדך מתבודד בבית הכנסת אחר עלות השחר תקיף הדוכן שבעה פעמים עם שבח אנא בכח ותאמר המזמור והפסוקים אשר באו במעירי שחר הנזכר בסדר ר״ה בדף קמ״ח. תכוין לבך בהם ותתענג. עוד טוב לכוין בכל שעה מיום התענית מלבד הנדרש בקרבן תענית להשפיע עליך מדה אחת מי״ג תקוני דיקנא דאריך שהם בפסוקי מי אל כמוך פוק עיין בתומר דבורה כי שם פירש אותם החכם. ובי״ג שעות אחרות תכוין להמשיך עליך הארת י״ג מדות אל רחום וחנון ותכוין עוד בי״ג

on the day when you sanctify yourself with a fast on the eve of the New Moon, as I intended in the fourth discourse in "Korban Ta'anit" [Sacrifice of Fasting]. This is in addition to other supplications and the confession appropriate for a fast day, which are from page 180 to page 186. We have already made these customary among the upright and the community on the fast day of our prayer group, with God's help, for it is appropriate for every person to feel distress at the time of the waning of the moon.

However, I found in the words of the Sage that it is not appropriate to look at an eclipse of the moon. The proof is that the priest does not pronounce "unclean" to a house afflicted with leprosy (which only applies specifically in the Land of Israel) until after he has left the doorway of the house, for when a bride begins her menstrual period, it is not appropriate for her attendant to declare this in her presence. This is the reason for "a plague appears to me" rather than "a plague" [in the biblical text]—to avoid spreading evil reports about the Land of Israel, the king's daughter. For the plague is a "closing affliction" that closes and prevents the divine flow toward "the land which the Lord your God cares for continually."

If you merit on the fast day to direct your actions according to the mystery of supernal rectification, how good it is! For early in the morning on that day, when you are alone in seclusion in the synagogue after sunrise, encircle the platform seven times while reciting the praise "Ana Bekoach" and say the psalm and verses that appear in Me'irei Shachar mentioned in the Rosh Hashanah order on page 145. Direct your heart to them and take pleasure.

It is also good to focus in each hour of the fast day, beyond what is required in Korban Ta'anit, on drawing upon yourself one measure from the thirteen rectifications of the beard of Arich Anpin, which are in the verses "Who is a God like You," go and look in "Tomer Devorah" for the Sage explained them there. And in the other thirteen hours, intend to draw upon yourself the illumination of the thirteen attributes: "God, merciful and gracious..." And also focus on the thirteen attributes of Arich that clothe themselves

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept that the waning of the moon represents a time of increased divine judgment, requiring special spiritual practices to mitigate these cosmic forces.

[ii] The author provides a kabbalistic interpretation of the biblical phrasing for identifying leprosy in houses (Leviticus 14:35), explaining that the indirect language avoids speaking negatively about the Land of Israel, which is personified as a royal daughter.

מדות דאריך המתלבשים בתשעה
תקוני דזעיר. כללם יחד ב״ך
ישראל והם אותם שהזכיר משה
בעון המרגלים ובאו רמוזים
בפסוקי מן המצר ככתוב בספרי
המקובלים. ובכל שעה תכוין
למדה אחת כנזכר הרי כ״ב
ובד׳ שעות הנשארות עד כ״ו
תכוין שעה ראשונה לשם אדנות
ושניה לשם הויה ושלישית לשם
אהיה ושעה רביעית משולבים
כלם יחד שכן סוד י״ג מדות הם
בשלש מערכות השמות האלו
ומאד מכוונת כוונה זו לתענית
בהפסקה מבעוד יום שעולה כמו
י״ג תעניות כאשר כתבנו בקרבן
תענית פרק רביעי. ויכוין בסוד
התענית חלב ודם המתמעט
דוגמא לחלב הניתן על גבי אש
המזבח[i] דהיינו כללו חסד בדין.
והדם היה נזרק סביב למזבח
שהוא בסוד הרחמים ודאי. שכן
היו מלבנין המזבח והדם אדום
על הלבן ובזה תכוין ברתיחת
חולשת גופך והרי זה קשר גדול.
עוד החלב שהוא גשמי נעשה ריח
ניחוח רוחני. הדם שהוא רוחני
נעשה גשמי בגוף המזבח להורות
קשר העולמות זה בזה. עוד
טוב לכוין בכל תפלותיו לעולם
ובפרט ביום התענית בחתימת
מקבץ נדחי עמו ישראל לתקון
טפות ש״ז הנדחין לחצונים[ii] ואם
תרגיש בעצמך ביום הנזכר מן
המנחה ולמעלה רוח טהרה
תתפלל בבית הכנסת אתה לבדך
מעוטף בציצית ומוכתר בתפלין
בכריעה על ברכים תפלה נוראה
מזווגא דמטרוניתא[iii] אשר היא
תקון קדמונים הנה הנה במעירי
שחר בסדר יום הכיפורים בדף

in the nine rectifications of Zeir Anpin. All together they equal 22 [in Hebrew: כ״ב/KaF-Bet] Israel, and they are the ones Moses mentioned in relation to the sin of the spies, alluded to in the verses "From the straits," as written in the books of the Kabbalists. In each hour, focus on one attribute as mentioned—that makes 22—and in the four remaining hours until 26, focus the first hour on the divine name Adnut, the second on the name YHVH, the third on the name Ehyeh, and the fourth hour on all of them interwoven together, for the secret of the thirteen attributes is in these three arrangements of divine names. This intention is very appropriate for a fast that begins while it is still day, which is equivalent to thirteen fasts, as we wrote in Korban Ta'anit, chapter four. 60R 65R 70R

One should focus on the mystery of the fast: the fat and blood that are diminished [in the body during fasting] correspond to the fat placed upon the altar's fire, which combines kindness with judgment. And the blood was sprinkled around the altar, which is certainly in the realm of mercy. For they would whiten the altar, and the red blood [would be visible] upon the white, and with this you should focus on the heat of your body's weakness, and this creates a great connection. Additionally, the fat, which is physical, becomes a spiritual pleasant aroma. The blood, which is spiritual, becomes physical in the body of the altar, showing the connection between the worlds. 75R 80R 85R

It is also good to focus in all one's prayers always, and particularly on the fast day, during the conclusion of the blessing "Who gathers the dispersed of His people Israel," on rectifying the seed that has been scattered to external forces. And if you feel within yourself on the mentioned day, from the afternoon prayer onwards, a spirit of purity, pray in the synagogue by yourself, wrapped in tzitzit and crowned with tefillin, kneeling on your knees, the awesome prayer of the union of the Divine Feminine, which is an ancient rectification—it is there in Me'irei Shachar in the Yom Kippur order on page 90R 95R

[i] This presents a profound mystical interpretation of fasting where the body's deprivation of fat and blood becomes a spiritual sacrifice comparable to Temple offerings, transforming physical discomfort into cosmic repair.

[ii] The author reveals a kabbalistic intention for the standard blessing about gathering Israel's exiles, connecting it to the mystical concept of rectifying seminal emissions, which were believed to create negative spiritual entities.

[iii] This describes a specific kabbalistic prayer practice with precise ritual elements (tzitzit, tefillin, kneeling) designed to effect cosmic unification of masculine and feminine divine aspects.

קנ״ה ועפעפיך יזלו בה מים
100 ותשא אל אלוה פניך ורעיונך.
ויש עוד תפלה מיוחדת לג׳
צומות וליום תשעה באב אחר
חצות הודפסה אחר סדר של
כל יום. ובסדר סוכות תמצא
105 תפלה הגונה לומר אותה בליל
ראשון בעת כניסתך לסוכה
בכבוד אושפיזין עילאין. ותפלת
רבי אלעזר בן ערך הרגלנו
לומר אותה ג״כ בשמיני עצרת
110 אך לא סופי עניינים שמדברים
מהחתימה. הנה פקדתי עליך
אחי דרכי והטוב בעיניך עשה
כי אתה תבחר ולא אני ואם
תורגלת בתחנות ובקשות אחרות
115 מאותם המורגלים בפי רוב עם
ישראל טוב שתאחז בזה וגם מזה
אל תנח ידך כי יום אחד בחדש
בלבד תקדישהו כלו לאלהיך אך
לעולם ישן מפני חדש אל תוציא
120 שכל המשנה ופורש מהם ידו על
התחתונה ואורח עולם תשמור
אשר גבלו וציינו ראשונים הגם
שהניחו לנו אבותינו ג״כ מקום
להתגדר ולזכות בו עצמנו
125 וזולתנו. ובהלכות שבת באורח
חיים סי׳ ל״ד בסופו בא בדברי
המגיה כי טוב להפריש י״ח
פשוטים לצדקה והם במקום
חטאת. וז״ל אם חלל שבת
130 צריך להתענות ארבעים יום
שני וחמישי ולא ישתה יין ולא
יאכל בשר ויתן במקום חטאת
י״ח פשוטים לצדקה.[i] ואם ירצה
לפדות התענית יתן בעד כל יום
135 י״ב פשוטים וביורה דעה סימן
קמ״ה על מי שהיה משמש עם
הטהורה ושגג ופירש בקושי אחר
שאמרה לו נטמאתי כתב ג״כ
תקון זה של מ׳ תעניות אמנם
140 בפדיון התעניות כתב נכון שיתן
כפי ממון שיש לו כי עשיר יתן
יותר קצת מהעני עכ״ל. וכל

155—and let your eyelids flow with tears as you lift your face and thoughts to God. There is also a special prayer for the three fasts and for the Ninth of Av after midday, printed after the daily order. And in the Sukkot order, you will find a proper prayer to recite on the first night when you enter the sukkah in honor of the supernal guests. And we have made it customary to recite the prayer of Rabbi Eleazar ben Arakh also on Shemini Atzeret, but not the concluding matters that speak of the closing [of the festival]. 100R 105R

Behold, I have charged you, my brother, with my ways, and do what is good in your eyes, for you shall choose and not I. And if you are accustomed to other supplications and petitions from those common in the mouths of most of the people of Israel, it is good to hold onto this and also not to let go of that, for only one day in the month should you dedicate entirely to your God. But never discard the old because of the new, for whoever changes and separates from them, his hand is on the lower side, so keep to the path of the world which the ancients established and marked out, even though our fathers also left us room to distinguish ourselves and merit through it, both for ourselves and for others. 110R 115R 120R

In the laws of Shabbat in Orach Chaim, section 34, at the end, the editor writes that it is good to set aside 18 simple coins for charity, and they are in place of a sin-offering. And these are his words: “If one desecrated the Sabbath, one must fast for forty days on Mondays and Thursdays, and not drink wine or eat meat, and give in place of a sin-offering 18 simple coins to charity. And if one wishes to redeem the fast, one should give for each day 12 simple coins.” And in Yoreh De’ah, section 145, regarding one who was intimate with his ritually pure wife and withdrew with difficulty after she told him “I have become impure,” he also wrote this remedy of 40 fasts, but regarding the redemption of the fasts, he wrote that it is proper to give according to one’s means, for a rich person should give a bit more than a poor person, end of quote. And all who are pure of hands will increase in strength. 125R 130R 135R 140R

[i] The author cites a specific halakhic remedy for Sabbath violation: giving 18 coins to charity as a substitute for the sin-offering that would have been brought in Temple times. This practical guidance integrates legal and mystical approaches to atonement.

טהר ידים יוסיף אומץ:[i]

פרק כ׳

Chapter 20

מצאתי כי רבי חנינא בן דוסא
כשהיה מתפלל על החולים היה
מניח ראשו בין ברכיו. ע״כ אחד
מתקוני התענית הוא לכבוש פניו
בקרקע[ii] זמן הרבה מהיום ההוא
ובזה מסוגל להקנות הכנעה
בנפשו ובעת שמתחנן בו הנה
מה טוב להניח ראשו בין ברכיו
כמו שמצינו באליהו דכתיב ביה
וישם פניו בין ברכיו[iii] ולהיות
שאלת המטר שאלה כוללת כל
צרכי עליונים ותחתונים לכן
הוצרך התעוררות גדול להוריד
השפע מבחינת רישא עד סוף
מקום ההתפשטות ולמתק תרין
קשרין תתאין שהם בסוד הברכים
כנודע בסוד בני השפחות כדי
שכל אחוריהם של ד׳ קשרין
יהיו ביתה. וכדאיתא באגדת

I found that Rabbi Hanina ben Dosa, when praying for the sick, would place his head between his knees. Therefore, one of the rectifications of fasting[A] is to press one's face to the ground for a long time on that day, which is conducive to acquiring humility in one's soul. And when one beseeches during this time, how good it is to place one's head between one's knees, as we find with Elijah, of whom it is written "and he put his face between his knees." Since the request for rain is a comprehensive request including all the needs of the upper and lower realms, a great awakening was required to draw down divine influence from the aspect of the "Head" to the end point of expansion, and to sweeten the two lower knots[B] that are in the mystery of the knees, as is known in the mystery of "the children of the handmaids,"[1] so that all the back parts of the four knots would turn inward.

As is stated in the Aggadah on "One should not stand [to pray]," likewise when Rabbi Hanina sought

[A] Or: "one of the spiritual practices associated with fasting" — While 'rectifications' (תקונים) is the literal translation and conveys the kabbalistic concept of spiritual repair, 'spiritual practices' might be more accessible to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[B] Or: "to transform the two lower bonds from severity to mercy" — This alternate translation unpacks the kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening' (המתקה) more explicitly, making clear that it refers to the transformation of divine judgment into mercy.

[1] This refers to the kabbalistic interpretation of the children born to Jacob's handmaids (Bilhah and Zilpah) in Genesis. In mystical thought, they represent certain spiritual forces associated with the 'back' or external aspects of divine emanation, which need to be rectified or 'turned inward.'

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Part 6 (Korban Ta'anit/Sacrifice of Fasting) — The author refers here to his own work 'Korban Ta'anit' (Sacrifice of Fasting) which is Part 6 of Ma'avar Yabok, indicating this passage's connection to his broader discussion of fasting as spiritual remedy. | Cf. Taanit 8a — The author draws on the Talmudic principle that one who prays for others while needing the same blessing will be answered first, applying it to prayers for healing. | Cf. Tomer Devorah by Moses Cordovero — The author explicitly refers readers to 'Tomer Devorah' (Palm Tree of Deborah) by Moses Cordovero for an explanation of the 13 attributes of divine mercy, showing his reliance on and respect for this kabbalistic work. | Cf. Zohar on the 13 Rectifications of the Beard (Tikkunei Dikna) — The author references the Zoharic concept of the 13 rectifications of the beard of Arich Anpin, a complex kabbalistic idea about divine emanations and mercy, suggesting readers should meditate on these during specific hours of their fast. | Cf. Leviticus 14:34-35 (regarding leprosy in houses) — The author draws on the biblical procedure for a priest examining houses with leprosy-like afflictions to make a spiritual point about not announcing negative things in the presence of the affected party.

[ii] This practice of pressing one's face to the ground during prayer is described as a physical expression of complete humility and submission before God. It appears in several places in rabbinic literature as a particularly powerful posture for prayer in times of urgent need.

[iii] This refers to 1 Kings 18:42, where Elijah assumes this posture when praying for rain after the drought during his confrontation with the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel. This biblical precedent gives authority to the practice.

אין עומדים גם כן כשבקש רבי חנינא רחמים על בנו של רבי יוחנן בן זכאי ואמר הוא אלמלא הטיח בן זכאי פניו בקרקע כל היום[i] וכו׳ וכן מצינו באלעזר בן דורדיא שהניח ראשו בין ברכיו וגעה בבכיה וכן מצינו בתשובת רבינו האי בפי׳ ארבע נכנסו לפרדס[ii] מי שהוא הגון בכמה מדות זכורות ומבוארות כשמבקש להציץ בכח שכלו בהיכלות של מלאכי מרום יש לו דרכים לעשות שישב בתענית ימים ידועים ומניח ראשו בין ברכיו וילחוש בפיו שירות ותושבחות הרבה שהם מפורשות ובכן מציץ מפנימיו ובחדרי שכלו כמו שהוא רואה בעיניו היכלות וצופה בשכלו באלו הוא נכנס. מהיכל להיכל ורואה מה שישיגו ויש שתי משניות שהתנאים שונים אותו בדבר זה הנקרא היכלות רבתי והיכלות זוטרתי[iii] וסוד שני מיני היכלות הוא כי ע״י השבעה היכלות שביצירי[iv]ה משם פונים בהסתכלות בינתם להיכלות עליונות שבבריאה ומהם לאורות שבאצילות המתלבשים בהם וראו רבי עקיבא וחביריו

mercy for the son of Rabbi Yohanan ben Zakkai, he [Rabbi Yohanan] said, "Had ben Zakkai pressed his face to the ground all day, etc." Similarly, we find with Eleazar ben Dordaya that he placed his head between his knees and burst into tears. And we also find in the responsum of Rabbenu Hai explaining "Four entered the Pardes" that one who is worthy in several attributes, remembered and clarified, when seeking to gaze with the power of his intellect into the palaces of the supernal angels, has ways to do so: he should sit in fasting for specific days, place his head between his knees, and whisper with his mouth many songs and praises that are specified. Thus, he gazes from within himself and in the chambers of his intellect,[1] as if seeing with his eyes the palaces and beholding with his intellect as if he were entering from palace to palace, seeing what they perceive.

There are two Mishnaic texts that the Tannaim study on this matter, called Heikhalot Rabbati and Heikhalot Zutarti. The secret of these two types of palaces is that through the seven palaces of Yetzirah (Formation), from there they turn in the contemplation of their understanding to the supernal palaces of Beriah (Creation), and from them to the lights of Atzilut (Emanation) that clothe themselves in them. Rabbi Akiva and his colleagues who entered the palaces[2] did so just as they entered the Pardes. Thus explained the Arukh that they had Halakhot Rabbati and Halakhot Zutarti, and they saw the watches of the angels in their stations, and

[1] This describes a technique of spiritual visualization where the mystic does not physically see the heavenly palaces but perceives them through inner spiritual vision or intellectual contemplation.
[2] This connects the Heikhalot literature's accounts of heavenly ascent with the famous Talmudic story of the four who entered Pardes (Paradise), suggesting that they represent the same mystical experience described in different ways.

[i] This alludes to a story in Berakhot 34b where Rabbi Hanina ben Dosa prayed for Rabbi Yohanan ben Zakkai's son, and when the son recovered, Rabbi Yohanan ben Zakkai commented that had he himself pressed his face to the ground in prayer all day, it would not have been as effective as Rabbi Hanina's brief prayer.
[ii] This refers to the famous Talmudic account (Hagigah 14b) of four sages who entered 'Pardes' (literally 'orchard,' but interpreted as an acronym for different levels of textual interpretation or as a reference to mystical paradise): Ben Azzai, Ben Zoma, Aher (Elisha ben Abuyah), and Rabbi Akiva. Only Rabbi Akiva is said to have 'entered in peace and departed in peace.'
[iii] These are two major texts from the Heikhalot literature, an early corpus of Jewish mystical writings (3rd-7th centuries CE) that describe ascents to the heavenly realms and visions of the divine throne (Merkavah mysticism). 'Rabbati' means 'greater' and 'Zutarti' means 'lesser,' indicating two different compilations of these mystical teachings.
[iv] This refers to the kabbalistic cosmology where creation is divided into four worlds: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action). The seven palaces or chambers in the world of Yetzirah are mystical structures that the initiate contemplates in order to ascend to higher spiritual realms.

שנכנסו להיכלות כמו שנכנסו
לפרדס וכן פירש הערוך
כי היו להם הלכות רבתי
והלכות זוטרתי ורואין משמרות
המלאכים במעמדם והיאך היכל
אחר היכל וכו׳ כי ההכנה
לשמיעת תפלה ולסכות ברוח
הקדש הוא בהטחת פניו בקרקע.
ואם יארע ליל טבילת אשתו
במוצאי תעניתו היה טוב לו מאד
וירגיל עצמו בתפלה ובפסוקי
היחוד שהם בסוד הקומה השלמה
העליונה בסוד נפש רוח ונשמה
על הסדר אשר בא בסוף מעירי
שחר שלנו מכוונת קודם הזווג
כנתבאר שם בפי הפשט כי
אין לכל דעת נקיה כדאמרו
בירושלמי דחגיגה ונהורן הוא
דלא בריא.[i] ויזהר לבל יפסול
זרעו במחשבה בלתי טהורה
ח״ו ואמרו בזהר פ׳ יתרו שכל
הפוסל זרעו אין מתיישב הפיסול
ההוא עד שלשה דורות ולכן
משפחה שנפל בה איזה פיסול
אפילו לא יהיה ממזר כגון בן
קדשה או נדה וכיוצא לא יערבו
זרעם בזרעו עד אחר שלשה
דורות ברם שם כוונו לנושא
אשה שאינה הוגנת לו ויהי מה גם
פסול המחשבה קראוה בגמרא
בני תמורה[ii] ובמה שכוונתי שם
בחבור פסוקים שבאו על זה כל
חכם ומבין מדעתו ימצא בהם
דבש וחלב הראויים ליכנס תחת

how one palace follows another, etc. For the preparation for hearing prayer and for attaining the Holy Spirit is by pressing one's face to the ground. 50R

If the night of his wife's ritual immersion happens to fall on the night after his fast, this would be very good for him. He should accustom himself to prayer 55R and to the verses of unification, which are in the mystery of the complete supernal structure,[A] in the mystery of nefesh, ruach, and neshamah, according to the order that appears at the end of our "Me'irei Shachar,"[1] to be intended before marital union, as 60R explained there according to the plain meaning, for not everyone has pure knowledge, as they said in the Jerusalem Talmud of Hagigah, "and it is the light that is not created." He should be careful not to invalidate his seed with impure thoughts,[2] God forbid. 65R And they said in the Zohar, Parashat Yitro, that anyone who invalidates his seed, that invalidation does not settle until three generations. Therefore, a family in which some invalidation has occurred, even if not [producing] a mamzer, such as the son 70R of a prostitute or [conceived during] menstruation and the like, should not mix their seed with his seed until after three generations. However, there they were referring to one who marries a woman who is unsuitable for him. Whatever the case, they also 75R called defective thoughts in the Talmud "children of substitution." And in what I intended there in the compilation of verses about this, every wise person who understands from his own knowledge will find in them honey and milk worthy to enter under his 80R tongue, for this is the way I kept to direct the intention of everything to the extent my humble hand could reach, according to the true principles in the

[A] Or: "in the esoteric concept of the complete divine configuration" — This alternate translation might better convey to modern readers that this refers to the complete structure of divine emanations (sefirot) in kabbalistic thought.

[1] This appears to be a reference to the author's own prayer collection titled 'Illuminators of Dawn,' which contained specific prayers and meditations to be recited before marital relations to ensure proper spiritual intention.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic belief that the spiritual quality of a person's thoughts during marital relations affects the spiritual nature of any children conceived. Pure, holy thoughts were believed to draw down a holy soul, while impure thoughts could have the opposite effect.

[i] This Aramaic phrase means 'and it is the light that is not created,' possibly referring to the idea that not everyone is capable of receiving or understanding mystical illumination, as this requires special preparation or inherent spiritual capacity.

[ii] This term refers to children conceived when the husband's thoughts are directed toward someone other than his wife during marital relations. The Talmud (Nedarim 20b) discusses this concept, suggesting that such thoughts can have spiritual effects on the offspring.

לשונו כי דרך זו שמרתי לכוין
כוונת כל דבר עד מקום שידי
הצעירה מגעת על פי ההקדמות
האמיתיות באמרות טהורות של
פסוקי הנבואה כנזכר במנחת
אהרן מפרק ז׳ ואילך: [i]

pure sayings of the prophetic verses, as mentioned in "Minchat Aharon"[1] from chapter 7 onward.

פרק כ״א

Chapter 21

על כן בני ורעי שנו מדותי שהם
תרומות מד״ת וקבלה[ii] ותרא
דברים ישנים מסודרים וכתובים
על נייר חדש וסדרא וחושבנא
בעלמא ידענא בהון ומאן דידעי
לדרוש סמוכים אלו מן התורה
בהם יצפצף להגות בכבוד
אומר כלו דוגמא למה שפעל
ועשה בכח התורה בורא עולם
שלהיותו רחוק מכל התגשמות
האציל והמשיך פנימיות רוחניות
התורה[iii] עד גדר התלבשות
נאות ומוכן להמצא דבר גשמי יש

Therefore, my sons and friends, study my principles,[A] which are offerings derived from Torah and Kabbalah. You will see ancient matters arranged and written on new paper. I know their order and calculation in the world,[B] and whoever knows how to seek connections to these from the Torah should chirp and meditate upon them with respect for all that is said. This parallels what the Creator of the world accomplished through the power of the Torah.[2] Because God is far removed from any physical form, He emanated and drew forth the inner spirituality of the Torah to the point of appropriate embodiment, making it ready

[A] Or: "Therefore, my sons and friends, repeat my teachings" — The Hebrew verb 'shanu' can mean both 'study' and 'repeat/review.' In traditional Jewish learning contexts, repetition is often emphasized as a key learning method, so this alternate translation captures that nuance.

[B] Or: "I know only their basic order and calculation" — The phrase 'bealma' can connote 'merely' or 'simply,' suggesting the author is being humble about his knowledge, claiming to know only the basic structure rather than a comprehensive understanding.

[1] This is a reference to another work by the author, Aaron Berechia of Modena, whose name is reflected in the title 'Offering of Aaron.'

[2] The author is drawing a comparison between human study of Torah and God's use of Torah for creation. Just as God used the Torah to create physical reality from spiritual essence, humans can use proper Torah study to strengthen and maintain creation.

[i] Cf. Talmud Berakhot 34b — The author uses this Talmudic account to demonstrate the power of assuming a posture of extreme humility (placing head between knees) when praying for healing. | Cf. 1 Kings 18:42 — The biblical reference to Elijah putting his face between his knees when praying for rain serves as a scriptural basis for the prayer posture being described. | Cf. Avodah Zarah 17a — This Talmudic account of a penitent who placed his head between his knees provides another example of this prayer posture being effective for eliciting divine mercy. | Cf. Hagigah 14b — The author connects mystical ascent practices to the famous Talmudic account of four sages who entered the 'Pardes' (mystical paradise), suggesting similar techniques for spiritual elevation. | Cf. Heikhalot literature — The author references these ancient Jewish mystical texts as sources for techniques of spiritual ascent through visualization of heavenly palaces. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Yitro — The author uses this Zoharic teaching to emphasize the importance of pure thoughts during marital relations, as improper thoughts have spiritual consequences lasting three generations.

[ii] The author employs wordplay here; 'terumot' means 'offerings' or 'contributions,' but also connects to the word 'Torah' in the phrase 'mi-d't' (from Torah). This suggests his teachings are distilled essence of Torah and Kabbalah.

[iii] This language reflects kabbalistic cosmology, where divine emanation (atzilut) allows the transcendent to manifest in increasingly concrete forms, paralleling how God uses the Torah as an instrument to create physical reality from spiritual essence.

מאין וזהו ה׳ קנני ראשית דרכו
כי היתה כלי אומנתו ובקיומנו
אותה ובהגיגנו בה בהויתה
ובלשונה יתחזק מה שנעשה בה
וזהו פירוש נגידים אדבר ירצה
שכל דברותיה נגידים ושרים
שכל התורה שמותיו של הקב״ה
ואפילו התפשטות כסא הכבוד
הוא על ידי התורה וכן תמיד
מהוה שפע אור מפנימיותה וזהו
משחקת לפניו בכל עת באדם
השמח ובשמחתו מגלה פנימיות
לבו מלבד כי אמרו כי שמ״ח
אורות היה האור הראשון במנין
שמ״ח[i] והקול יוצא מגילוי שפע
אור התורה ופנימיותה ועל פי
הדברים האלה חזר הדין לסיני
ונאדר כח הפסוקים בכתבם
ובלשונם הרבה יותר מאותם
הנפסקים בסבינא חריפא בדברי
שיחה ביניהם[ii] הגם כי תהיה
שיחה נאה בעיני הבריות דוגמא
לשברי כלי חרס שבמקדש כי היו
נבלעים במקומן הגם שבתוכן
היו שירי טהרה. הנה הלוים
בהרנינם על דוכנם הגם שלא
היה דומה כוונת הכהן בקרבן
שהיה מקריב יום ראשון לקרבן
המקריב יום שני וכן בכל ימי
השבוע. וכן יחוד שעושה קרבן
העשיר חלוק מיחוד הגורם קרבן
העני ולבן מומין אין בו כי היה

for physical things to be created ex nihilo. This is the meaning of "The LORD acquired me at the beginning of His way" [Proverbs 8:22], for the Torah was His crafting instrument.[A] When we fulfill it and meditate upon it in its true essence and language, what was created through it is strengthened. 15R

This is the interpretation of "I will speak noble things" [Proverbs 8:6]—meaning that all of its utterances are noble and princely, for the entire Torah consists of the names of the Holy One, blessed be He.[1] Even the extension of the Throne of Glory exists through the Torah. Similarly, it constantly generates a flow of light from its inner essence, which is the meaning of "rejoicing before Him at all times" [Proverbs 8:30], like a person who in his joy reveals his inner heart. Beyond this, they said that there were 348 (שמ״ח) lights in the primordial light, corresponding to the numerical value of שמ״ח (joy), and the voice emerges from the revelation of the flowing light of the Torah and its inner essence. 20R 25R 30R

Based on these principles, the law returned to Sinai, and the power of the verses as they are written and in their language is much greater than those cut with a sharp knife by casual conversation between them, even if such conversation appears pleasant in people's eyes. This is analogous to the broken earthenware vessels in the Temple that were absorbed in their place,[2] even though they contained remnants of purity. 35R 40R

Indeed, the Levites in their joyful singing on their platform, even though the intention of the priest with the offering he brought on the first day was not the 45R

[A] Or: "This is the meaning of "The LORD created me as the beginning of His way" [Proverbs 8:22], for the Torah was His artisan's tool" — The Hebrew 'kanani' in this biblical verse has been variously translated as 'acquired,' 'created,' or 'possessed.' Additionally, 'kli umnuto' could be rendered as 'artisan's tool' to better capture the sense of divine craftsmanship in creation.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the Torah is composed entirely of divine names in various combinations and permutations. This is not merely metaphorical but understood literally in mystical tradition—each letter and word contains divine power.

[2] This reference to broken vessels that are 'absorbed in their place' likely alludes to the rabbinic teaching that broken sacred vessels were buried within the Temple grounds rather than discarded. The author uses this as a metaphor for how even imperfect speech about sacred matters retains some residual holiness.

[i] The author employs gematria, Jewish numerology, noting that the Hebrew word for 'joy' (sameach) has the numerical value 348 (שמ״ח), which he connects to primordial light. This reflects the kabbalistic practice of finding deeper meanings through numerical equivalences.

[ii] The phrase 'cut with a sharp knife' (b'sakina charifa) is a vivid metaphor for interrupting or fragmenting biblical texts with human conversation, which the author sees as diminishing their spiritual power.

בסוד דרך הנשר בשמים מקום
שאין קליפות[i] ועוד אין הקב״ה
מדקדק עם העני על פגם עונות
כדכתיב כי לא בזה ולא שקץ
50 עונות עני וגו׳ ולכן בין זכר בין
נקבה הכל עולה כי אין תמות
וזכרות בעוף כי העשיר פגם
עונו במקום העושר והדל אינו
משיג לפגום בעליונות ברם יש
55 עני שנאחז בספירות העליונות
והוא השמח בחלקו ובבחינה זו
נקרא עשיר וב״ש שהיה הכהן
חלוק בכוונותיו בקרבן השבתות
וראשי חדשים וימים טובים על
60 הדרך אשר נבאר אם יגמור ה׳
על ידינו בספר טעמי המצות בלי
נדר ופרטות כוונות אלו נרמזו
ונמצאו בשיר המיוחד על הקרבן
בכל יום ולכל חילוק זמן כנדרש
65 שם וכן שיר של פגעים ובשהיו
מוסיפין על העיר והעזרות
הכל היה במזמורים ופסוקים
וכן אמרו בגמרא פסוקי דרחמי
כי קדש מוציא קדש[ii] וזהרורי
70 דשמשא הוא שמש ומגן ה׳ אלהים
אינון כשמשא ודאי והרבה יותר
ממה שכתוב כאן כתוב וערוך
בהקדמת הרב הגדול בעל
מעשה אפוד כי הפליא לדבר
75 מזה ואמר כי הקדמונים קראו
לארבעה ועשרים מקדש י״ה
ונתעצם בטענותיו והוכיח מפי
השמועה והראיה כי הקהלות
המתחננים בתחנונים מיוסדים
80 במאמרי הכתובים והמזמורים
הם מושגחים ונמלטים מכל פגע

same as the offering brought on the second day, and so throughout the days of the week. Similarly, the unification created by the rich person's offering differs from the unification caused by the poor person's offering. Therefore, blemishes do not apply to birds, 50R
as they exist in the secret of "the way of the eagle in the sky" [Proverbs 30:19], a place without shells (kelipot). Moreover, the Holy One, blessed be He, is not exacting with the poor regarding the flaws of sins, as it is written, "For He has not despised nor 55R
abhorred the affliction of the poor" [Psalms 22:25]. Therefore, whether male or female, all ascend, for there is no perfection or masculinity in birds, because the rich person's sin blemishes in the place of wealth, while the poor cannot reach to blemish in 60R
the higher realms.[1] However, there is a poor person who grasps the higher sefirot—one who rejoices in his portion—and in this aspect he is called rich.

All the more so that the priest differed in his intentions regarding the offerings of Sabbaths, New 65R
Moons, and festivals, in the manner that we will explain if the Lord enables us to complete the Book of Reasons for the Commandments, without making a vow. The particulars of these intentions were alluded to and found in the special song for the offering 70R
each day and for each division of time as expounded there, as well as in the Song of Afflictions. When they would add to the city and the courtyards, everything was done with psalms and verses. Similarly, they said in the Talmud regarding verses of mercy, 75R
that holiness brings forth holiness, and the rays of the sun are indeed like the sun, for "the LORD God is a sun and shield"[2] [Psalms 84:12].

Much more than what is written here is written and arranged in the introduction of the great 80R
rabbi, author of Ma'aseh Efod, for he spoke won-

[1] The author presents an unusual mystical interpretation of why bird offerings (typically brought by the poor) don't need to be perfect: the wealthy person's spiritual reach extends to higher realms where their sins can cause damage, while the poor person's influence is more limited. This reverses conventional assumptions by suggesting spiritual disadvantages to wealth.

[2] The author is making a mystical point about emanation—just as sunrays share the essential nature of the sun itself, so too words derived from scripture retain the divine power of their source. This supports his argument for the superiority of prayers composed of biblical verses.

[i] The author provides a mystical interpretation of Proverbs 30:19 ('the way of an eagle in the sky'), suggesting it refers to a spiritual realm above the influence of negative forces (kelipot). This explains why bird offerings don't require the same perfection as animal offerings.

[ii] The phrase 'holiness brings forth holiness' expresses a fundamental principle that true holiness is generative—the words of scripture produce holy effects because they originate from divine holiness itself.

ובחתום דבריו כלל ואמר סוף
דבר העבודה האמיתית לאלהים
הוא העוסק בתורה ובנביאים
ובכתובים ואפילו ההגיה לבד
הוא סבה לקיום העולם בסגולה
ונתעצם הרבה להוכיח ולברר
אמתת דברים אלו וקיימו
ואושרו דבריו השלמים וכן רבים
שהעלום בספריהם ולא אאריך
להעתיק דבריהם כי בהא שוו
חכימיא וספריא ודרשיא ורישי
עמא:[i]

drously about this and said that the ancients called the twenty-four books of the Bible "the sanctuary of Yah." He strengthened his arguments and proved from tradition and evidence that communities who supplicate with prayers founded on the sayings of Scripture and psalms are watched over and delivered from all harm. In concluding his words, he summarized and said, "In the end, the true service to God is engagement with Torah, Prophets, and Writings,[1] and even recitation alone is a means for the world's existence in a wondrous way." He greatly exerted himself to prove and clarify the truth of these matters, and his complete words were affirmed and validated, as were many who raised them in their books. I will not elaborate by copying their words, for in this the sages, scribes, preachers, and leaders of the people are in agreement.

פרק כ״ב

Chapter 22

עוד כתב ה״ר יונה החסיד כי
אין טוב לומר בשבחי המקום רק
פסוקים וכן פסק מהרר״י קארו
בסוף סי׳ קי״ג כי בהון בוצינין
מתנהרן ברעותא[ii] שהוא שפע
הכתר באחדותא שפע החכמה
באחוותא שפע הבינה והגינה
זרועיה תצמיח על כן אנכי חזון

Rabbi Jonah the Pious also wrote that it is best to use only scriptural verses when praising God, and Rabbi Joseph Karo similarly ruled at the end of section 113, for through them "the lights illuminate with divine will," which is the flow from Keter (Crown) in unity, the flow from Chokhmah (Wisdom) in brotherhood, and the flow from Binah (Understanding),[2] whose arms produce shelter.

[1] The author concludes by citing the Ma'aseh Efod to emphasize that even simple recitation of biblical texts has cosmic significance for maintaining the world's existence. This reflects the kabbalistic view that proper engagement with sacred texts sustains creation itself.

[2] This passage describes how biblical verses activate a flow of divine energy through the highest sefirot (divine emanations). The author uses technical kabbalistic terminology about the three highest divine attributes: Keter (Crown), Chokhmah (Wisdom), and Binah (Understanding).

[i] Cf. Proverbs 8:22-31 — The author draws on the personification of Wisdom in Proverbs 8 and applies it to the Torah, viewing the Torah as God's pre-existent instrument for creation. This interpretation follows rabbinic tradition that identifies the personified Wisdom in Proverbs with the Torah itself. | Cf. Zohar — The notion that 'the entire Torah consists of the names of the Holy One' is a fundamental kabbalistic concept found throughout the Zohar. Similarly, the description of divine emanation creating physical reality reflects core Zoharic cosmology about how the divine extends into the material world through successive emanations. | Cf. Ma'aseh Efod by Isaac ben Moses Halevi (Profiat Duran) — The author refers to this 14th-century work to bolster his argument that prayers composed of biblical verses have special efficacy and divine protection. This reflects the ongoing medieval and early modern debate about the relative value of biblical verses versus later poetic compositions in prayer. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Berakhot 32b — The reference to Levites singing on their platform (dukhan) connects to Talmudic discussions about Temple service. The author uses this to illustrate how different intentions can exist within formally identical ritual actions, just as different days' offerings might appear similar externally but differ in their spiritual effect.

[ii] This phrase uses technical Aramaic kabbalistic terminology to describe how biblical verses activate divine illumination. The phrase literally means 'through them, the lights are illuminated with divine will.'

הרבתי בראש ותוך וסוף של סדר
החרבן מכל יום וביום השבת יש
תקוני דודין ורעין ושם תקוני
הרעיה שהיא בינה ותקוני הכלה
שהיא המלכות[i] ותקוני רעיה הם
ממעלה למטה ותקוני הכלה הם
ממטה למעלה אמנם תקוני החתן
הם ביושר ותקוניו עד השוקים
מה שתקוני הרעה אינם מתפשטים
רק עד שדים שהם חסד גבורה
נכללים כאחד אל הבחינה
הממוצעת בגוה קו האמצעי
וסוד כל זה מתבאר למשכיל
והכל רמז שלמה בשיר השירים
בחכמה רבה והפיוטים קצרים
הם מכוונים לכוולת הפסוקים
ולהיות שמלבד תקוני אלו הכלה
תתקשט גם כן בכ״ב אותיות
שבפסוקי אשת חיל[ii] בידוע
סודם למביני החכמה לכן באו
שם בכתובים והכ״ו קשוטי
הכלה המתפרשים בפסוקי
ישעיהו ומתחילים יסיר ה׳
את תפארת העכסים[iii] יחזקאל
ביאר תקונם אחד לאחד גם הם
באו בסדר תשעה באב ותחנות
ובקשות שאינם פסוקים שבאו
במעירי שחר הנ״ל בדברים
העקרים הלכתי לי אל הגדולים
ורבים דא״א להשיב עליהם
ע״ד שאמרו בתוספת׳ דטהרות
אפשר להשאיל על היחיד וא״א
להשאיל על הרבים וכל אחד

Therefore, I have greatly incorporated scriptural verses at the beginning, middle, and end of the daily destruction liturgy. On the Sabbath, there are rectifications of "lovers and friends," including rectifications of the "Shepherdess" (which is Binah) and rectifications of the "Bride" (which is Malkhut). The rectifications of the Shepherdess descend from above to below, while the rectifications of the Bride ascend from below to above. The rectifications of the "Bridegroom," however, proceed in a direct line, extending down to the legs, whereas the rectifications of the Shepherdess extend only to the breasts,[1] which represent Chesed and Gevurah (Kindness and Strength) united as one in the intermediary aspect within the central column.[2] The secret of all this becomes clear to the discerning, and Solomon alluded to it all with great wisdom in the Song of Songs. The liturgical poems, though brief, are aligned with the full meaning of the biblical verses.

Besides these rectifications, the Bride is also adorned with the twenty-two letters found in the verses of "Woman of Valor" (Proverbs 31), as is known to those who understand wisdom, which is why they appear in the Scriptures. The twenty-six adornments of the Bride, which are explained in the verses of Isaiah beginning with "The Lord will remove the splendor of the anklets," and which Ezekiel clarified one by one, also appear in the Ninth of Av liturgy.

For supplications and petitions that are not scriptural verses, which appear in my "Illuminators of Dawn" prayer book[3] mentioned above, I turned to

[1] The author is using the metaphor of a human body to describe the different extents to which divine attributes (sefirot) manifest. This anthropomorphic approach is common in Kabbalah, where divine structures are often mapped onto a cosmic human form called Adam Kadmon.

[2] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of the central column (kav ha'emtza'i) of the sefirot, where Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) balances and unites the right column of Chesed (Kindness) and the left column of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment).

[3] The author refers to his own prayer collection or prayer society called 'Me'irei Shachar' (Illumi-

[i] This passage employs kabbalistic terminology from the Zohar, where 'lovers and friends,' 'Shepherdess,' and 'Bride' are technical terms for divine configurations. In Kabbalah, Binah (Understanding) is the third sefirah, often portrayed as the Divine Mother, while Malkhut (Kingdom) is the tenth sefirah, representing the Divine Feminine in her worldly aspect.

[ii] The author refers to a kabbalistic tradition that connects the 22 verses of the 'Woman of Valor' poem (Proverbs 31:10-31) with the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet, seeing them as symbols for different aspects of the divine feminine.

[iii] The author refers to the 26 feminine ornaments listed in Isaiah 3:18-24, which kabbalists interpret as representing spiritual qualities of Malkhut (the divine feminine). The number 26 is significant as it corresponds to the numerical value of the divine name YHVH.

מהם הם דוגמא לכל דורות
ה״ה רבי נחוניא בן הקנה ורבי
אלעזר בן ערך ופרקי היכלות
מרבי ישמעאל ורבינו סעדיה
והרמב״ן והחכם קורדו״אירו
וגורי האר״י והחכם ד״אטו
והחכם מורי מפאנו זצ״ל ומהם
קרתי וששיתי מים זכים וברורים
הגם שהרבה הוספתי וגרעתי
בכל מקום לפי הענין המכוון
אלי ועכ״ז אם לא מפני הסבה
הכתובה בסוף החבור ההוא
לא הייתי מביא אותו אל בית
הדפוס. וגבול זה הגבילו
לנו הראשונים כי לא חדשו
מדעתם במקום שמצאו להתלות
בדברי חכמי המשנה הגמרא.
הנה בסדר התרעה בפה כתב
מהרר״י קארו באורח חיים סימן
תקע״ו ז״ל תקלו נוסח תפלה
שהיא הרכבת ב׳ תפלות של
ר׳ ישמעאל בן אלישע כ״ג ושל
חוני המעגל וכבר ידוע שבימי
התעניות של הגשמים הרבה
מהיום דהוא עסקם היה בקריאת
התורה ולהפטיר בנביאים כאשר
הובא בגמרא ובסי׳ תקע״ו
וכן המעמדות שהיו מתפללים
על הקרבן. ושליח צבור ראוי
להתפלל בתענית אמרו בגמרא
כי צריך שיהיה רגיל לקרא
בתורה ובנביאים ובכתובים
וכן חזינן במס׳ יומא פרק יום
הכפורים דרב הוה פסיק סדרא
קמיה דרבי ופרש״י מקרא של
נביאים ושל כתובים ובמקומות
הרבה נראה שעקר בקשותיהם
היו במקראות יבא שלום ינוח על
משכבו הגאון האר״י כי העידו
עליו תלמידיו במנהגיו שלא היה
חפץ רק בסדרי הראשונים וז״ל
התלמיד הכותב שם גם מורי לא
היה חפץ בשום פזמון או פיוט
מאותם שסדרו אחרונים רק מן
הראשונים כמו תפלת רבי עקיבא
ורבי ישמעאל ורבי אלעזר בן
ערך ורבי אלעזר הקלירי

the great authorities whose words cannot be questioned, as they said in the Tosefta of Taharot: "One can question the ruling of an individual but not the ruling of the many." Each of these authorities serves as a model for all generations: Rabbi Nechunya ben HaKanah, Rabbi Eleazar ben Arakh, the Hekhalot chapters of Rabbi Ishmael, Rabbeinu Saadia, Ramban, Rabbi Moses Cordovero, the disciples of the ARI, Rabbi Da'ato, and my teacher the sage of Fano, of blessed memory. From these sources I drew and drank pure, clear waters, though I added and subtracted much in each place according to the intended purpose. Nevertheless, if not for the reason written at the end of that work, I would not have brought it to press.

The early authorities established this boundary for us: they did not innovate on their own in places where they could rely on the words of the Mishnaic and Talmudic sages. Thus, regarding the order of oral blasts, Rabbi Joseph Karo wrote in Orach Chaim section 576: "They established a prayer formula combining two prayers: one from Rabbi Ishmael ben Elisha the High Priest and one from Honi HaMe'agel." It is well known that during rain fast days, much of their time was spent reading Torah and the Prophetic portions, as mentioned in the Talmud and in section 576, and similarly with the Ma'amadot prayers that were recited for the sacrifices.

Regarding the prayer leader on a fast day, the Talmud states that he should be someone familiar with Torah, Prophets, and Writings. Thus we see in Tractate Yoma, Chapter "Yom HaKippurim," that Rav would recite the biblical portion before Rabbi, which Rashi explains as readings from the Prophets and Writings. In many places, it appears that their primary petitions were scriptural passages.

May peace come and rest upon the resting place of the Gaon, the ARI, for his disciples testified about his practices that he desired only the arrangements of the early authorities. As the disciple wrote there: "My teacher had no desire for any hymn or liturgical poem composed by later authorities, only those of the early ones such as the prayer of Rabbi Akiva, Rabbi Ishmael, Rabbi Eleazar ben Arakh, and Rabbi Eleazar HaKalir (about whom he testified that he had some relationship with Rabbi Eleazar the son of Rabbi Shimon). This is because they were composed

nators of Dawn), which appears in multiple places throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

(שהוא העיד עליו שהיה לו איזה
90 התיחסות עם רבי אלעזר ברבי
שמעון)[i] ודוגמתם לפי שנתקנו
על דרך האמת אך לא אחרונים
שלא ידעו דרך הקבלה ואינם
יודעים מה שאומרים וטועים
95 בסדר דבורם בלי ידיעה כלל
ועיקר ולא היה אומרם כלל
ובפרט יגדל אלהים חי ודוי
אשמנו באומר ובפועל וכו׳ וכל
שאר ודוים דר׳ נסים ואדרו״טיל
100 וכיוצא לא היה רוצה לאומרם
כלל עכ״ל דוגמא לזה אמרו
במס׳ כלים אין לך מחשבה
מועלת אלא מחשבת בעלים שהם
בני דעה:[ii]

according to the path of truth, unlike later ones who did not know the way of Kabbalah and do not understand what they are saying,[1] making errors in the order of their words without any knowledge whatsoever. He would not recite them at all, particularly 'Yigdal Elohim Chai' and the confession 'Ashamnu' with its 'in word and deed,' etc., and all other confessions by Rabbi Nissim and Adriotil and the like—he would not recite them at all." This exemplifies what they said in Tractate Kelim: "No thought is effective except the thought of the owners who have understanding." 90R 95R 100R

פרק כ״ג

Chapter 23

אם יאמר אומר מצאתי און לי
בשבחי כי אספתי חמרים חמרים
מאגדות הגמ׳ ומדרשים חצונים
אשיב כדאמר רבי טרפון לרבי
5 אלעזר המודעי ביומא עד מתי
אתה מגבב דברים ומביא עלינו
ואומר כי מלבד שזו מלאכת

If someone should say, "I have found strength for myself in my praises, for I have gathered heaps upon heaps from the aggadot of the Talmud and external midrashim," I would respond as Rabbi Tarfon said to Rabbi Elazar HaModa'i in Yoma: "How long will you continue to collect sayings and bring them upon us?"[2] And I say that besides this being the 5R

[1] This passage reflects the ARI's (and the author's) preference for liturgy composed with proper kabbalistic knowledge. This approach became influential in Jewish prayer traditions, particularly in Italy and Safed, where kabbalistic intentions (kavvanot) were considered essential to effective prayer.

[2] This is a reference to a Talmudic exchange where Rabbi Tarfon criticizes Rabbi Elazar HaModa'i for excessive compilation of sayings. The author uses this as a rhetorical device to criticize those who merely collect aggadic material without deeper understanding.

[i] This refers to a tradition, attributed to the ARI, that Rabbi Eleazar HaKalir (an early liturgical poet from approximately the 6th-7th century CE) had some mystical connection with Rabbi Eleazar son of Rabbi Shimon (a Tanna from the 2nd century CE). This claim suggests a spiritual continuity between these figures separated by centuries, possibly implying reincarnation.

[ii] Cf. Song of Songs — The author sees Song of Songs as a mystical text that encodes secrets about the relationships between divine attributes (sefirot), particularly Tiferet (the Bridegroom), Binah (the Shepherdess), and Malkhut (the Bride) | Cf. Proverbs 31 (Woman of Valor) — The author interprets the Woman of Valor passage as a kabbalistic text where each verse corresponds to one of the 22 Hebrew letters, creating a complete system of adornments for the divine feminine (Malkhut) | Cf. Isaiah 3:18-24 — The author interprets Isaiah's list of 26 feminine adornments as representing spiritual qualities of the divine feminine (Malkhut) rather than merely physical ornaments | Cf. Ezekiel's visions — The author suggests that Ezekiel's visions contain detailed explanations of the spiritual qualities represented by the adornments mentioned in Isaiah | Cf. Hekhalot literature — The author considers the mystical Hekhalot literature, which describes heavenly palaces and ascent experiences, as a legitimate source for liturgical composition | Cf. Tosefta Taharot — The author uses this citation to justify relying on multiple traditional authorities rather than introducing personal innovations in prayer composition

השיר היא ולא חכמה וברננה
דשותא לא מפקינן רחמי ואם
קצת מן הראשונים עשו כן אין
דנין איש מהאיש כדאמרי׳ במס׳
יומא פרח ח׳ כי הם היו יודעים
למתח את י״ם הגד״ול[i] כדאמרי׳
בירושלמי בפרק אין מעמידין
על רבי מונא ורבי תנחום עוד
ידענו כי אפי׳ אגדות אשר באו
בגמרא הם שיחתם של תלמידי
חכמים וכל שכן שאר האגדות
שחוץ ממנה וקראום בגמרא
מילי דבדיחותא בשמחה של
מצוה כדאמרי׳ בשבת פרק
במה מדליקין בפי׳ שמחה של
מצוה ובפסחים כי רבה מקמי
דפתח להו לרבנן אמר מילתא
דבדיחותא ובדחי רבנן לסוף
יתיב באימתא ופתח בשמעתא.
וזה נראה ברור מדברי רש״י
שכתב למעלה על מה שבא שם
שאילו שאלה זו מרבי תנחום
מהו לכבות בוצינא דנורא מקמי
באישא בשבתא ופתח ואמר
באינון מילי דאגדתא הנזכר
שם ושם כתב רש״י כך היו
רגילים לפתוח באגדה תחלה
שהיא דומה לשאלה ובגמרא
דירושלמי דמס׳ הוריות פ״ג
דרשו על בעלי אגדה פסוק ולא
ישליטנו האלהים לאכול ממנו.
עוד רב נחמן דהוא מחסידי

craft of poetry rather than wisdom[A]—and with the jubilation of mere talk, we do not elicit mercy[B]—and even if some of the early authorities did so, we do not judge one person by another,[1] as we say in Tractate Yoma, chapter 8, for they knew how to stretch "the Great Sea" [of Torah], as is said in the Jerusalem Talmud in the chapter "Ein Ma'amidin" concerning Rabbi Muna and Rabbi Tanchum.[C] 10R 15R

Furthermore, we know that even the aggadot that appear in the Talmud are merely the casual conversation of the sages, and all the more so the other aggadot outside of it. They called them in the Talmud "matters of levity," like "joy of a mitzvah," as is explained in Shabbat, chapter "Bameh Madlikin," regarding the definition of "joy of a mitzvah." And in Pesachim, before Rabbah would begin teaching the rabbis, he would say something humorous to cheer up the rabbis, and afterwards he would sit in awe and begin the lesson. This is clearly evident from Rashi's words, who wrote above, concerning what appears there about the question from Rabbi Tanchum about whether it is permitted to extinguish a lamp because of danger on Shabbat, and he began by speaking about those matters of aggadah mentioned there. And there Rashi wrote: "Thus they were accustomed to begin with aggadah first, which resembles the question." And in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Horayot, chapter 3, they expounded regarding the masters of aggadah the verse: "God does not allow him to enjoy it" [Ecclesiastes 6:2]. 20R 25R 30R 35R

Moreover, Rav Nachman, who was among the pious of Babylonia, is reported in chapter "Bnei Ha'ir"

[A] Or: "besides this being mere poetic craftsmanship and not true wisdom" — This alternate translation more clearly conveys the author's dismissive attitude toward poetry as compared to genuine wisdom, emphasizing the contrast between artistic composition and true spiritual knowledge.

[B] Or: "and through joyful speech alone we cannot evoke divine mercy" — This alternate translation more explicitly conveys the theological implication that mere pleasurable speech cannot effectively bring about divine compassion, which requires more substantive spiritual content.

[C] Or: "as is mentioned in the Jerusalem Talmud in the chapter "Ein Ma'amidin" about Rabbi Muna and Rabbi Tanchum" — This is a slight refinement that better reflects the reference to a text rather than a direct quotation.

[1] This phrase refers to the rabbinic principle that we cannot necessarily apply the same standards to different individuals. The author is suggesting that while earlier sages could properly incorporate aggadic material, contemporary authors lack the same capacity.

[i] This appears to be a metaphor where "the Great Sea" represents the vast expanse of Torah knowledge that earlier sages knew how to "stretch" or expand through their deep understanding. The author suggests that previous generations had greater capacity to properly incorporate aggadic material.

דבבל אמרו בפרק בני העיר
שלא רצה להספיד ההוא צורבא
דרבנן דלא תני שמעתא הגם
דהוה תני ספרא וספרי ותוספתא
וכל שכן שלא היה מספידו אם
היה לומד באגדה לבד ואם
יצא מפי אומר לכנות הפיוטים
והקינות המתחדשים בשם דברי
שיחה הגם לפי דעת הממציאן
שתו בשמים פיהם במילי דלא
מקניאן ולא ממסרן לכל שליח
שותא דא אפיקו על מין שיחה
הנזכר אשר מזה תרדנה עינינו
דמעה כי שחה לעפר נפשנו
נפש דוד באשר דרש הרב
הגאון קורדוא״רו[i] על פסוק
אקים את סוכת דוד הנופלת
שתמיד בעונותינו נופלת ופירשו
בזהר פ׳ פקודי שהיא יורדת
דרך המעלות ממשנה לברייתא
ואמר כי ירדה מהברייתא
לאמוראים ומאמוראים לרבנן
סבוראי ומרבנן סבוראי לגאונים
ומגאונים לנגידים ומנגידים
לחכמים עד כי שרו חכימיא
למהוי כספריא וספריא כעמא
דארעא ועמא דארעא אזלא
ומדלדלא ואין דורש ומבקש
וכו׳ עד כי גיורא בשמי
שמיא[ii] ועולם הפך ראינו כי
דברי אגדה ושיחה נעלם עתה
בראש כל חולה לתהלה וקצת מן
החיים המתהלכים תחת השמש
הולכים על דרך שיחתן זה

to have refused to eulogize a certain rabbinic scholar who did not study halakhic teachings, even though he studied Sifra, Sifrei, and Tosefta, and certainly he would not have eulogized him if he had studied only aggadah. And if a speaker should categorize newly composed liturgical poems and lamentations as "mere talk"—even though according to their creators' intent they have "set their mouth in heaven" with matters that are not transferable or transmissible to any messenger—they have cast such speech in a manner that causes our eyes to shed tears, for "our soul is bowed down to the dust" [Psalms 44:26], [A]the soul of David, as the great Rabbi Cordovero expounded on the verse "I will raise up the fallen booth of David" [Amos 9:11], which continually falls because of our sins.[1]

It is explained in the Zohar, Parashat Pekudei, that it descends through levels—from Mishnah to Baraita—and he said that it descended from Baraita to the Amoraim, and from the Amoraim to the Rabbanan Savorai, and from the Rabbanan Savorai to the Geonim, and from the Geonim to the Negidim [leaders], and from the Negidim to the sages, until the sages began to be like scribes, and the scribes like common people, and the common people going and becoming impoverished, with no one seeking or inquiring, etc., until a convert is in the highest heavens. And we have seen the world turned upside down, for words of aggadah and conversation are now concealed at the head of every sick person to praise, and some of the living who walk under the sun follow this path of conversation. And among them are those whose light and name are pure, and they prefer it as one of the heavenly hosts,[B] and with their throat

[A]Or: "our soul is bowed down to the dust—the Davidic soul" — This alternative better conveys the mystical concept of 'soul of David' as representing the collective Jewish spiritual essence rather than simply referencing the biblical King David personally.

[B]Or: "And among them are those whose luminous reputation is unblemished, yet they value

[1]This reflects the kabbalistic concept that the divine presence (Shekhinah, symbolized by the 'booth of David') descends through successive historical periods due to Israel's sins. This descent parallels the decline in spiritual understanding through generations of scholars.

[i]This refers to Rabbi Moses Cordovero (1522-1570), the prominent kabbalist from Safed whose works, including Pardes Rimmonim, were highly influential in systematizing Kabbalah. The author of Ma'avar Yabok appears to be drawing on Cordovero's interpretation of spiritual decline through successive generations.

[ii]This phrase "until a convert is in the highest heavens" appears to be a proverbial expression indicating a complete inversion of the proper order of things—suggesting that the world has been turned upside down when those with less traditional standing occupy the highest positions in spiritual matters.

ומנייהו דנהורא דשמיהו בריא
ועדיף להו כאחד מצבאי המרום
וביה בגרון לשם יקראו ואלומי
אלמי לקליהו באמור אליו אנא
נפשאי כתבת ויהבת[i] ולית סוגין
דיהא מיניה על דרך שאמרו
בירושלמי דבתרא. את כל זאת
חזיתי ואספר להגיד לכם אלופי
ובני ורעי כי לא ימושו חוקי
דברי הנבואה מפיכם ומנייהו
לא תזועו:[ii]

they call out to the Name, and they forcefully silence those who say to them, "I myself have written and given, and there is no fence that can come from it," as they said in the Jerusalem Talmud at the end of Bava Batra.

All this I have seen, and I tell it to declare to you, my teachers, my sons, and my friends, that the statutes of the words of prophecy shall not depart from your mouth,[1] and from them you shall not waver.

פרק כ״ד

Chapter 24

כתב מהרר״י קארו בסי׳ תר״ו
תקנת קדמונינו שלא להוציא שם
רע על המתים[iii] פן ח״ו יגביר
בקטרוגו כחות הדינים עליו שכן
המתין הקב״ה שלא לעורר כחות
הדין במבול בשבעת ימי אבלו
של מתושלח הצדיק[iv] מלבד

Rabbi Joseph Karo wrote in section 606 that our ancestors instituted a practice not to speak ill of the dead, lest, heaven forbid, one strengthen the forces of judgment against them through accusation. Indeed, the Holy One, blessed be He, waited to unleash the flood during the seven days of mourning for the righteous Methuselah, besides the fact that there was

such talk as if it were equal to the celestial hosts" — This alternative better captures the irony in the original text, where even respected scholars sometimes inappropriately elevate simple speech to the level of celestial wisdom.

[1] This echoes biblical language from Joshua 1:8 about the constancy of Torah study. The author concludes by encouraging adherence to authentic prophetic tradition rather than the poetic elaborations he has been criticizing.

[i] This Aramaic phrase approximates to "I myself have written and given," suggesting that these scholars claim their compositions as their own creation rather than as transmission of traditional wisdom. The author criticizes this self-referential approach to religious writing.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pekudei — The author references this Zoharic passage to illustrate the spiritual decline through successive generations of Jewish scholarship, from Tannaim to his own time, suggesting that with each decline, authentic mystical understanding becomes more obscured by mere talk. | Cf. Amos 9:11 — The author mentions Cordovero's interpretation of this verse to illustrate the decline of authentic Jewish mystical tradition (the 'booth of David'), which has 'fallen' through successive generations but will eventually be restored. This serves as a metaphor for the decline in quality of religious discourse from profound mystical insight to mere talk. | Cf. Tractate Yoma — The author uses this reference to criticize those who merely compile aggadic material without deeper understanding. This serves as a proof text for his argument against valuing quantity over quality in religious discourse. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — While criticizing others for merely collecting aggadot, the author implicitly defends his own compilation method in Ma'avar Yabok as being qualitatively different, suggesting that his work organizes material according to authentic mystical principles rather than simply gathering entertaining stories. | Cf. Rabbi Moses Cordovero's works — The author aligns himself with Cordovero's kabbalistic perspective, viewing history as a process of spiritual decline where each generation is further removed from direct mystical understanding. This framework justifies the author's concern about the proliferation of mere poetic compositions that lack genuine mystical insight.

[iii] This reflects the Jewish ethical principle of not speaking ill of the dead (לא לדבר רע על המתים), which is both a matter of respect and, as the text explains, has spiritual implications for the deceased's soul.

[iv] According to rabbinic tradition, the Flood was delayed for seven days to allow for the mourning period of the righteous Methuselah, who died just before the Flood began. This tradition appears in Genesis Rabbah 32:7.

שהיה גם כן למעלה מבול רוחני׳
ופן תצטער נפשו העולה ויורדת
המתין לו והם דברי המרדכי 10R
במסכתא יומא ויש סמך לדבר
בהגדה דרבי חנינא פ׳ ואתחנן
ושם אמר עוד כי כשאמרו למשה
שיש רגע לפטירתו פתח ואמר
ברוך שמו חי וקיים לעולם ועד 15R
ומזה ילמד כל אדם. וקריאת
שמע סמוך למיתה הוא תקון
ודאי להיותו תקון רמ״ח אברי
הקומה העליונה ברמ״ח תיבות
שבו בנודע[i] וכל שכן אם יהיה 20R
בזמנו כדאמרי׳ על זה אמרו
בלבבכם על משכבכם ובפרט אם
יכוין במספר מפקד תיבותיו מה
שכתבנו בסוף מאמר שפתי רננות
ובששים הפסקותיו[ii] ליתן ריוח 25R
בין הדבקים שבין אחורי זעיר
לנוקביה כנודע למבינים שבהם
מתמתקים בחות הדין ומצננים
אשו של גיהנם למטה וכן אמרו
שם כי הוא ביקש מחילה מישראל 30R
חצי שעה קודם מיתתו ומה יעשו
אזובי קיר.[iii] ונראה לי ממה
שמצאתי בפ׳ ויקהל בזהר כי
ממונה דקאים לסטר דרום אומר
נגד התפלה דסלקא מגו עקו 35R
ותבירא דלבא קודשא בריך
הוא יחוס לקבלך ועלך יתמלי
רחמין שטוב לומר בזה בשנפטר

also a spiritual flood occurring in the upper realms. And lest the soul of the departed, which ascends and descends, be distressed, He waited for him. These are the words of Mordecai in Tractate Yoma, and there is support for this in the Aggadah of Rabbi Hanina in the portion Va'etchanan. There it is also stated that when they told Moses there was but a moment until his death, he began by saying, "Blessed is His name, who lives and endures forever," and from this every person should learn.

Reciting the Shema near the time of death is certainly a rectification,[1] for it repairs the 248 limbs of the supernal structure through its 248 words, as is known. This is especially so if recited at the proper time, as they said regarding the verse "Speak in your hearts upon your beds." Particularly if one focuses on the number of its words as we wrote at the end of the discourse "Lips of Joy," and on its sixty pauses which create space between the attached aspects,[2] specifically between the back of Zeir Anpin and its feminine counterpart, as is known to those who understand, for through these the forces of judgment are sweetened[3] and the fires of Gehenna below are cooled. They also said there that Moses requested forgiveness from Israel half an hour before his death, so what should ordinary mortals do?[4]

It seems to me, from what I found in the Zohar portion Vayakhel, that the appointed angel who stands to the south speaks against the prayer that rises from distress and brokenness of heart: "May the Holy One, blessed be He, have compassion upon

[1] The Hebrew term 'tikkun' (תקון) has mystical significance beyond simple 'repair'—it refers to cosmic restoration and the harmonization of divine forces through human ritual actions.

[2] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that pauses in prayer create 'cosmic space' that allows divine energies to flow properly between different spiritual realms. The technical terminology refers to the relationship between masculine and feminine aspects of divinity.

[3] The kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgments' (המתקת הדינים) refers to transforming divine severity into mercy through proper spiritual actions, a central concept in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death rituals.

[4] The Hebrew uses the idiom 'hyssop of the wall' (אזובי קיר) from 1 Kings 4:33, contrasting humble plants with the mighty cedar, to express human insignificance compared to Moses—if even Moses needed forgiveness, how much more so ordinary people.

[i] The Shema prayer and its accompanying blessings traditionally contain 248 words, corresponding to the 248 positive commandments in Torah and the 248 limbs said to be in the human body according to rabbinic tradition.

[ii] This refers to a kabbalistic practice of pausing sixty times during the recitation of the Shema, corresponding to specific mystical intentions (kavvanot).

[iii] A biblical idiom from 1 Kings 4:33, literally "the hyssop that grows in the wall," used figuratively to refer to ordinary people in contrast to the great (like Moses in this context), suggesting "if even Moses needed to ask forgiveness, how much more so ordinary people."

מן החולה אחר בקירתו ויוסיף
40 על זה התפלה שעשה אברהם
אבינו ושרה בעת צרה הנזכרת
במדרש תנחומא שהוא רבונו של
עולם עשה למען רחמיך וחסדיך
ולמען שמך הגדול ואל תביש
45 החולה הזה מסברו וכל חולי
עמך ישראל יהיו בכלל הברכה
והחנינה וכתוב שם מאן דבעי
צלותא בצערא יתהפך ליה דינא
לרחמי וזה אמר על המתפלל
50 על חלומו ואם החולה הוא מבין
דברי חכמים טוב להרגילו לומר
לפעמים תפלה נוראה שבא
בספר התקונים אשר הדפסתיה
במעירי שחר דף רמ״ב עמוד א׳.
55 ולמען לא תהיה שגורה בפי הכל
לא הדפסנוה בסוף סדר שבת
קדש ששם היה מקומה. עוד ממה
שאמר להם בבקשה מכם זכרו
אותי ואת עצמותי בשתכנסו
60 לארץ למדנו שבכל מקום קדוש
ועת רצון זכות יהיה לנפטר
להזכיר נשמתו וכבר נתננו טעם
לשבח לזה פרק ג׳ ממאמר ג׳
וממה שכתב הרמב״ן ז״ל בסוף
65 פ׳ ויחי נראה שאין להזכיר
סמוך למיתתו שם רשעים ובפרט
אם הם אחיו או קרוביו ע״ש
על פסוק שמה קברו את יצחק
ואמרו בספרי פ׳ פנחס והובא
70 בילקוט פ׳ ואתחנן על פסוק
כבוד ה׳ יאספך מלמד שהמקום
נכנס בנשמותיהם של צדיקים
וכונסם בנחת רוח ובכבוד
ואמר שמיתת כל הצדיקים גם

you and may you be filled with mercy."[C] It is good
to say something like this when departing from a 40R
sick person after visiting them. One should add to
this the prayer composed by our father Abraham and
Sarah in their time of distress, mentioned in Midrash
Tanchuma: "Master of the Universe, act for the sake
of Your mercies and kindnesses, and for the sake of 45R
Your great Name, and do not disappoint this sick
person from their hope, and may all the sick of Your
people Israel be included in the blessing and grace."
It is written there that one who seeks prayer in dis-
tress will have judgment transformed to mercy for 50R
them.[D] This was said regarding one who prays about
a troubling dream.

If the sick person understands the words of the
sages, it is good to accustom them to occasionally re-
cite the awesome prayer found in the Book of Tikku- 55R
nim, which I printed in Me'irei Shachar, page 242,
column 1. In order that it not be fluently known by
everyone,[1] I did not print it at the end of the Sabbath
liturgy, where it would have belonged.

Furthermore, from what Moses said to them, "I 60R
ask of you, remember me and my bones when you
enter the land," we learn that in every holy place
and favorable time, there is merit for the departed
when their soul is mentioned.[E] I have already given a
praiseworthy reason for this in chapter 3 of the third 65R
discourse. And from what Nachmanides, of blessed
memory, wrote at the end of the portion Vayechi,
it appears that one should not mention the names
of wicked people near the time of death, especially if
they are one's brothers or relatives. See his commen- 70R
tary there on the verse "There they buried Isaac."

In Sifrei, portion Pinchas, and brought in Yalkut,
portion Va'etchanan, on the verse "The glory of the
Lord will gather you in," it teaches that the Divine

[C] Or: "The Holy One, blessed be He, will show compassion toward you and fill you with mercy" — This alternative uses future tense rather than subjunctive mood, which might better reflect the confidence expressed in the Aramaic original that divine compassion will actually occur, rather than merely expressing a wish.

[D] Or: "judgment will be transformed into mercy for them" — This alternative uses passive voice which might better reflect the Aramaic construction, emphasizing the transformation process itself rather than the person experiencing it.

[E] Or: "to mention their soul" — This alternative preserves the infinitive construction of the Hebrew original, emphasizing the active practice of mentioning the soul rather than the passive fact of it being mentioned.

[1] This reflects the traditional rabbinic approach of keeping certain powerful prayers somewhat restricted, based on the concern that esoteric prayers might be misused or misunderstood if too widely distributed.

היא מפי הקב״ה שנאמר והלך לפניך צדקך ונוטל נשמתו בנחת. וממה שהובא בילמדנו ובילקוט פ׳ חקת במיתת אהרן במדרש תהלים ובילקוט משלי ממקומות אלו נראה כי ראוי לצדיק לקבל עליו המיתה ברצונו כקרבן[i] הנאמר בו לרצונו לפני ה׳ וכן משה סיבב עמו הקב״ה בדברים ובסיבובים עד כי מרצון נפשו השלים עצמו למיתה והוא אמר פ׳ הצור תמים פעלו כשידע ודאי שנקנסה עליו מיתה כדאיתא במדרש רבה:[ii]

Presence enters into the souls of the righteous and gathers them with gentleness and honor. It states that the death of all righteous people comes directly from the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is said, “And your righteousness shall go before you,” and He takes their soul gently.[1]

From what is brought in Yelamdeinu and Yalkut in the portion Chukat concerning Aaron’s death, in Midrash Tehillim, and in Yalkut Mishlei, from these places it appears that it is fitting for a righteous person to willingly accept death as a sacrifice, as it is said, “of his own free will before the Lord.” Similarly, the Holy One, blessed be He, engaged with Moses in discussions and circuitous conversations until he willingly completed himself for death. And Moses said the verse “The Rock, His work is perfect” when he knew with certainty that death had been decreed upon him, as is found in Midrash Rabbah.

פרק כ״ה

Chapter 25

מצאתי מדרש תהלים שבשעה שהיה משה עולה לרקיע היה אומר שיר של פגעים[iii] ויפה עשה להקדים התפלה והפגיעה כי היתה צורתו צרה עם מלאכי

I found in Midrash Tehillim that when Moses was ascending to heaven, he would recite the Song of Afflictions[2] [Psalm 91]. He acted wisely by preparing himself with prayer and supplication, for his form was constricted among the high angels and celestial

[1] The text presents death for the righteous as a gentle, peaceful transition rather than a harsh judgment. This positive reframing of death is characteristic of Ma’avar Yabok’s approach throughout.
[2] I’ve included the clarification that this refers to Psalm 91, which is not stated explicitly in the original text but would be known to the intended audience.

[i] This presents a profound theological concept that the righteous should accept death willingly as a sacrifice (korban), transforming what might be seen as a punishment into a sacred offering to God.

[ii] Cf. Tractate Yoma — The citation to the Mordechai’s commentary on Tractate Yoma provides halakhic support for the prohibition against speaking ill of the dead, connecting it to the divine precedent of delaying the flood during Methuselah’s mourning period. | Cf. Midrash Tanchuma — The text references a prayer from Midrash Tanchuma attributed to Abraham and Sarah, suggesting it as an appropriate prayer when leaving a sick person, connecting ancient precedent to contemporary practice. | Cf. Zohar portion Vayakhel — The reference to the Zohar provides mystical context for prayer on behalf of the sick, suggesting that prayers arising from distress have special efficacy and explaining the spiritual mechanics behind them. | Cf. Book of Tikkunim — The author references a prayer from the Tikkunei Zohar that he published in his own work Me’irei Shachar, which he considers particularly powerful but deliberately kept somewhat esoteric by not including it in the standard Sabbath liturgy. | Cf. Nachmanides on Vayechi — This reference to Nachmanides’ commentary provides a scriptural basis for the practice of not mentioning wicked people near the time of death, especially if they are relatives of the dying person. | Cf. Sifrei, portion Pinchas — This reference provides a scriptural and midrashic basis for understanding death as a gentle gathering of the righteous by God, rather than a harsh judgment, supporting the text’s view of death as potentially positive for the righteous.

[iii] This refers to Psalm 91, which was known in rabbinic tradition as ‘Song of Afflictions’ or ‘Song of Demons’ (Shir Shel Pega’im) and was believed to have special protective powers against harmful spiritual forces.

מרום ומשרתי עליונים בהיותו
בתוך הענן ומתקרב והולך אל
האלהים פ׳ בשלח וכן אמרו
בגמרין מתירא אני שמא ישרפוני
וכו׳ עד כי אחז פני כסא ונשגב
מהם כי ידע שמו ברוך הוא
ובסוד ידיעת שם מ״ב[i] בפרט קם
ועלה וכשנבין במספר ההזאות
של פר ושעיר של יום הכפורים
שהיו מ״ג במספר שם מ״ב עם
הכולל[ii] ועם שפיכת היסוד היו
מ״ד במספ׳ דם[iii] הנה שבח שם
מ״ב מהפך הדם לחלב[iv] וכן טבע
האשה בימי עבורה שהדם נעבר
ונעשה חלב ולמיתוק הנעשה
לפני ולפנים בידוע לזוכה
בו יחשבו העומדי׳ המקריב
נשמתו קרבן לה׳ בבח שם מ״ב
המזכירים עליו בנזכר. וראוי
בעת זכירת שם מ״ב ליתן ריוח
בין כל שני תיבות בגון אנא
בכח. ואח״כ גדולת ימינך.
ואח״כ תתיר צרורה. לרמוז
שש כנפים הראשונות בשתים
יכסה פניו. והשניות בשתים
יכסה רגליו. ובשלישית בשתים
יעופף[v] וכן עד תשלום כל סדר
השם. וזה לבד מה שכתבנו
ולחכימיא ברמיזא ובכח שם זה
עם חסדי ה׳ אשר גברו עליו

ministers when he was within the cloud, drawing ever closer to God, as mentioned in Parashat Beshalach. Similarly, our sages stated in the Gemara: "I fear they might burn me," etc., until "he grasped the Throne of Glory and was protected from them, for he knew the blessed Name." Through the secret knowledge of the 42-letter Name in particular, he arose and ascended. 10R

When we consider the number of sprinklings of the bull and goat on Yom Kippur, which were 43 (corresponding to the 42-letter Name plus the collective[1]), and with the pouring at the foundation there were 44, matching the numerical value of "dam" (blood), we see how the praise of the 42-letter Name transforms blood into milk.[2] This mirrors the natural process in a woman during pregnancy, when blood is transformed and becomes milk. For the sweetening that occurs "within the innermost sanctuary,"[3] as is known to those who merit it, those who stand by will consider the one who offers his soul as a sacrifice to God through the power of the 42-letter Name that is recited over him, as mentioned. 15R 20R 25R

When reciting the 42-letter Name, one should leave a space between each pair of words, such as "Ana Bekoach," then "Gedulat Yemincha," then "Tatir Tzerura"—symbolizing the six wings [of the seraphim]: with the first two he covers his face, with the second two he covers his feet, and with the third two he flies. Continue this pattern until completing 30R 35R

[1]The Hebrew term 'im hakolel' refers to a kabbalistic numerological concept where one adds a number representing the whole in addition to the sum of the parts.
[2]This metaphor describes the kabbalistic concept of sweetening harsh judgments (blood) into mercy (milk), a fundamental principle in Jewish mysticism where divine names are used to transform spiritual qualities.
[3]The Hebrew 'lifnei v'lifnim' literally means 'before and within' and refers to the Holy of Holies in the Temple, but is used here metaphorically to indicate the deepest spiritual realms.

[i]This refers to the mystical 42-letter Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet), which was considered one of the most powerful divine names in Kabbalah. Knowledge of this name was believed to provide protection and spiritual power.
[ii]The author is drawing a kabbalistic connection between the 42-letter Divine Name (plus one for the 'collective' or whole) and the 43 sprinklings of blood performed by the High Priest in the Temple on Yom Kippur, suggesting that these ritual actions correspond to mystical realities.
[iii]The Hebrew word for blood (דם) has the numerical value of 44 (ד=4, מ=40), which the author connects to the 44 ritual actions in the Temple (43 sprinklings plus the pouring at the foundation).
[iv]This is a kabbalistic concept that the proper use of divine names can transform harsh judgment (symbolized by blood) into mercy and sustenance (symbolized by milk).
[v]This refers to Isaiah's vision of the seraphim (Isaiah 6:2) who have six wings: with two they cover their face, with two they cover their feet, and with two they fly. The author is connecting the structure of the 42-letter name prayer (Ana Bekoach) to this angelic imagery.

נעשו לו למשה המלאכים חברים
והסכימו כי יותן לו תורה ונתנו
בידו טובם בסוד לקחת מתנות
באדם[i] על הדרך שסיבב הקב״ה
בבאו משעיר ובהפיעו מהר
פארן כנדרש בזהר במקומו פוק
חזי רחימו׳ דמרן אם כן שיר
זה יהיה סולם גם כן להעלות
נשמת הנפטר וטוב שבכל עת
שיאמר פסוק כי בי חשק יכוין
לשם הנזכר שהוא בגימטריא כ״י
ב״י ולכן אמר הכתוב אחר כך
אשגבהו כי ידע שמי. ובמדרש
רבה פרשת חקת ובתנחומא
מצינו שפסוק היחוד מאכיל
המחבלים[ii] שהיה אומר בלעם
אם נתקל אחד מהם מכלום או
אם מחבלים באים ליגע באחד
מהם ממליך לקודשא בריך הוא
לא ישכב עד יאכל טרף כשהוא
אומר ה׳ אחד נאכלין המחבלין
לפניו ומלחשין אחריו ברוך
שם כבוד מלכותו לעולם ועד
ובורחין והוא נסמך בקריאת
שמע משומרי היום לשומרי
הלילה ושומרי הלילה מוסרין
אותו לשומרי הבקר וזה יהיה
אחד מהטעמים שהנהיגו לאומרו
סמוך ליציאת נשמה מלבד
כמה נוראות גדולות ובצורות
הנכללים בב׳ פסוקים אלו
ובסדר ק״ש כלו ובגמרא דר״ה
אמרינן כיון שאמר ובתורתך
כתוב וגו׳ שוב אינו צריך.
וממה דאמרו בירושלמי במדרש

the entire sequence of the Name. This is beyond what we have already written, and for the wise, a hint is sufficient.[1]

Through the power of this Name, together with God's abundant kindness toward him, the angels became Moses' companions and agreed that the Torah should be given to him. They placed their goodness in his hand, in fulfillment of "You have received gifts among men," in the manner that the Holy One, blessed be He, arranged when "He came from Seir and shone forth from Mount Paran," as expounded in the Zohar in its place. Go and see the love of our Master![2]

Similarly, this song [Psalm 91] serves as a ladder to elevate the soul of the deceased. It is beneficial that whenever one recites the verse "Because he has set his love upon Me" [Psalm 91:14], one should have in mind the aforementioned Name, which has the numerical value of "ki vi chashak" (כי בי חשק), and therefore Scripture continues, "I will set him on high because he knows My name."

In Midrash Rabbah, Parashat Chukat, and in Tanchuma, we find that the verse of unity [Shema] feeds the destructive forces.[3] Balaam would say: If one of them stumbles in any way, or if destructive forces come to touch one of them, he proclaims the kingship of the Holy One, blessed be He: "He will not rest until he consumes prey" [Numbers 23:24]. When one says "The Lord is One," the destructive forces are consumed before him, and they whisper after him, "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever," and then flee.

The person is entrusted in the recitation of the Shema from the guardians of the day[4] to the guardians of the night, and the guardians of the

[1] This translates the Hebrew expression 'l'chakimaya b'remiza' which indicates that certain mystical concepts are deliberately left unexplained because those with sufficient wisdom will understand from mere hints.

[2] The Hebrew 'rechimuta d'maran' uses an Aramaic term of endearment to refer to God, emphasizing the intimate relationship between God and Moses that enabled the giving of the Torah.

[3] This unusual expression refers to the kabbalistic concept that sacred words can neutralize negative spiritual entities by 'feeding' them transformative divine energy that renders them harmless.

[4] In Jewish mystical thought, different angels are appointed over different times of day and night, and the recitation of the Shema facilitates the proper transition of spiritual guardianship.

[i] This quotes Psalm 68:19, which is interpreted in rabbinic tradition as referring to Moses receiving the Torah from reluctant angels during his ascent to heaven.

[ii] The 'verse of unity' refers to the Shema (Deuteronomy 6:4), and the phrase 'feeds the destructive forces' reflects a kabbalistic concept that reciting sacred texts properly can neutralize negative spiritual entities by transforming them through holy words.

רבה מזבדי בר לוי ורבי יוסי בן
פטרס ורבי יהושע בן לוי דאמרין
תלתא פסוקי מן דדמכין[i] לראיה
כי הצדיקי רואין שכרן ביום
75 המיתה משם נראה כי סימן
טוב כשמתפטר האדם מתוך פ׳
טוב ומראין לו שכרו לפי שאין
מדרגת הצדיק מושגת לו אחר
מיתתו רק עד אחר י״ב חדש וזה
80 טעם מה שהמלאכי׳ מקדימים
לו שלום כדאמרי׳ במדרש רבה
פ׳ י״א ופ׳ ס״ב. וכתוב בספר
החסידים סי׳ רל״ד דף ל״ג שאין
נותנין לגוסס לאכול כי אינו
85 יכול לבלוע אבל נותנין בפיו
המים שמוצנין מן שלוו״יא בג״א
שג״א בלעז ויבתשוהו וימוצו
המרק ממנו ונותן בפיו שיוכל
לדבר אשרי היוצא מן העולם
90 בתמות[ii] ואשרי השומע דברי
תורה בכל יום ובה יהיו זממיו
כי בה ירבו ימיו:[iii]

night entrust him to the guardians of the morning. This is one of the reasons why the custom was established to recite it at the moment the soul departs, aside from the many great and profound mysteries included in these two verses and in the entire order of the Shema recitation. In the Gemara of Rosh Hashanah, it states: "Once one has said 'And in Your Torah it is written,' etc., one need not say more." 75R

From what is said in the Jerusalem Talmud and Midrash Rabbah by Mizvadi bar Levi, Rabbi Yose ben Patros, and Rabbi Joshua ben Levi, who said three verses before they slept—evidence that the righteous see their reward on the day of death—it appears that it is a good sign when a person departs while reciting a good verse, and his reward is shown to him. This is because the level of the righteous is not fully attained after death until after twelve months,[1] which explains why the angels greet him with "peace," as stated in Midrash Rabbah, chapters 11 and 62. 80R 85R 90R

It is written in Sefer Hasidim, section 234, page 33, that one should not give food to a dying person

[1] Jewish tradition holds that the soul undergoes a period of judgment and purification after death, typically lasting twelve months, before reaching its final status in the afterlife.

[i] The text references a tradition that these rabbis would recite three specific verses before sleeping, which parallels the practice of reciting specific verses before death. The connection suggests that sleep (as a 'small death') and actual death involve similar spiritual transitions.

[ii] The word 'temut' (תמות) can be translated as 'perfection' or 'integrity,' but also evokes the word for death (mavet), creating a wordplay suggesting that dying in a state of spiritual perfection is blessed.

[iii] Cf. Psalm 91 — This psalm is referred to as 'Shir Shel Pega'im' (Song of Afflictions/Demons) and was believed to have special protective properties against harmful spiritual forces. Moses is said to have recited it when ascending to heaven for protection, and it's recommended for recitation at deathbed contexts to facilitate the soul's safe transition. | Cf. Ana Bekoach prayer — This kabbalistic prayer contains the 42-letter Divine Name, structured as seven names of six letters each. The text explains the proper method of recitation with pauses between word pairs, connecting it to the six wings of the seraphim. This prayer was believed to have special protective powers when recited with proper intention. | Cf. Shema prayer — The Shema prayer is identified as particularly powerful at the moment of death. The text explains that this prayer 'feeds' and neutralizes destructive spiritual forces, creating protection for the dying person. It also facilitates the transition of the soul between spiritual guardians. | Cf. Zohar on Moses receiving the Torah — The passage alludes to a Zoharic interpretation of Deuteronomy 33:2 about God coming from Seir and shining from Mount Paran, connecting it to Moses receiving the Torah from the angels through the power of divine names. | Cf. Yom Kippur Temple Service — The passage refers to the High Priest's service on Yom Kippur, where blood was sprinkled in specific patterns. It connects the 43 sprinklings (counting the collective) plus the pouring at the foundation (44 total) to the 42-letter Divine Name plus the collective, and to the numerical value of 'dam' (blood = 44), showing how spiritual forces can transform blood to milk through proper mystical intention. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah and Tanchuma on Balaam — The text references midrashic sources explaining how Balaam recognized the power of the Shema to protect Israel from destructive forces. The recitation of 'The Lord is One' consumes harmful spiritual entities, who then whisper 'Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever' before fleeing.

because he cannot swallow, but one may place in his mouth water that has been cooled with sage (salvia) in the vernacular. Crush it and extract the juice, placing it in his mouth so he can speak. Blessed is he who departs from this world in perfection, and blessed is he who hears words of Torah every day and sets them as his purpose, for through them his days will be multiplied.

פרק כ״ו

Chapter 26

בימי הקדמונים היה המנהג בכל מקום לומר צדוק הדין עם יציאת נשמה כדתניא אין פותחין בצדוק הדין על המת עד שתצא נפשו ובראש חדש ובחול המועד אם עונים כלם כאחד מותר ואם אחד מדבר וכלם עונים אחריו אסור כך נמצא בחשובת הגאונים ובזהר פ׳ תרומה כתב כי בכל חדש מתקשרת הנשמה עם הרוח ונפש כאחד וכל הצדיקים מודים ומשבחים להקדוש ברוך הוא אף על קבריהם ואתגלימו כדיוקנא דהוו בהאי עלמא ועדון זה יהיה לדעתנו לסבת חדוש הלבנה העליונה דאוסיף חדוש בכלא בי״ד עתים של ראש החדש עד דקימא באשלמותא.[i] וכתב רב הא״י כי לומר צדוק הדין יחד דמי לעינוי ונשים במועד מענות ואם א׳ אומר וכלם עונים אחריו

In ancient times, it was customary everywhere to recite Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) at the moment of the soul's departure,[1] as it is taught: "One does not begin Tziduk HaDin for the deceased until the soul has departed." On New Moon days and during the intermediate days of festivals, if everyone recites it together, it is permitted; but if one person leads and the others respond after him, it is forbidden. This is found in the responsa of the Geonim. In the Zohar, Parashat Terumah, it states that each month the soul reconnects with the spirit and vital soul as one,[A] and all the righteous acknowledge and praise the Holy One, blessed be He, even from their graves, appearing in the same form they had in this world.[B] This delight occurs, in our view, because of the renewal of the supernal moon, which adds renewal to everything through the fourteen phases of the New Moon until it reaches fullness.

Rav Hai Gaon wrote that reciting Tziduk HaDin together resembles a communal lament, and women during festivals engage in responsive mourning. If

[A] Or: "The Zohar in Parashat Terumah states that each month the neshamah (higher soul) reconnects with the ruach (spirit) and nefesh (vital soul) as one unit" — This alternative translation preserves the specific Hebrew terminology for the three soul components (neshamah, ruach, nefesh), which might be valuable for readers familiar with kabbalistic concepts who want to understand the precise spiritual mechanics being described.

[B] Or: "and they materialize in the same form they possessed in this world" — The Aramaic term 'אתגלימו' has connotations of becoming embodied or materialized, suggesting a more substantial manifestation than just 'appearing'. This alternative better captures the mystical idea that the souls temporarily take on a quasi-physical form similar to their earthly bodies.

[1] Tziduk HaDin is a prayer affirming the justice of divine judgment, particularly recited during funeral services. The text discusses complex questions about when this prayer is appropriate, revealing tension between various ritual requirements: mourning customs, festival joy, and honoring the deceased.

[i] This kabbalistic explanation connects the monthly spiritual reunion of the soul components to the lunar cycle. The "supernal moon" refers to the divine feminine (Malkhut), and the fourteen phases refer to the fourteen days from new moon to full moon. This cosmic pattern is understood to create a monthly opportunity for spiritual renewal affecting the souls of the deceased.

דמי לקינה וכתב הרא״ש כי חכמי גרמיז״א אמרים אותו בראש חדש חנוכה ופורים דרך הלוך וחכמי מגנצ״א אין אומרים אותו אלא על חכם גדול והטעם יהיה כי אמרו בגמרא ואלו מגלחין אמר רבה בר רב הונא אין מועד בפני תלמיד חכם וכן חנוכה ופורים וה״מ בפניו אבל שלא בפניו לא אמר רב פפא ויום שמועה כבפניו דמי ובחלוק המנהגים שבין בני ארץ ישראל לבבל כתוב שלדברי שניהם אין אומרים צדוק הדין בחול המועד וכיון שאין צדוק הדין אין קדיש וכתב הרמב״ן כי צדוק הדין הוא הודאה וקבלת דין שמים[i] ור״י היה אומר שראוי היה לאומרו בבית הקברות אפילו כשקוברין אותו ביום טוב שלמה לא יצדיקו דין שמים ביום טוב כמו בחול ואם נקבר בחול המועד כתב שראה במחזור ויטר״י שיסדו זקנו ה״ר שמחה שהוא מתלמידי רש״י שפעם אחת אירע שהיו שם בני אדם מוחין בידם מלומר צדוק הדין ועמד רש״י ואמר עליו צדוק הדין וקדיש ע״ש במרדכי ריש מסכת מועד קטן ופוק חזי מאי עמא דבר וכבר כתבנו דעתנו בזה בפרק כ״ט מאמר ב׳. ומצאתי בירושלמי סמך למנהג שאומרים צדוק הדין על קברו של הנקבר בחול המועד או ברגל דאמרינן התם רבי אבון דמך במועד ולא גמל ליה רבי מונא חסדא אמר בתר מועדא עבדי ליה יקרא. וכתב גם כן שהלכה רווחת כי אין קוברין את המת אלא בטלית שיש בו ציצית בין טלית חדשה בין טלית מצויצת משלו וטעמא משום לועג לרש

one person leads and everyone responds after him, it resembles a dirge. The Rosh wrote that the sages of Worms recited it on New Moon days, Hanukkah, and Purim while walking, whereas the sages of Mainz would only recite it for a great scholar. The reason would be, as stated in the Talmudic tractate Mo'ed Katan: Rabbah bar Rav Huna said, "There is no festival in the presence of a Torah scholar," and this applies to Hanukkah and Purim as well. This only applies when the death occurs during the festival, but not if it happened before. Rav Papa said that the day one hears of a death is treated the same as if the death occurred that day. Regarding the differences in customs between the people of the Land of Israel and Babylonia, it is written that according to both opinions, Tziduk HaDin is not recited during the intermediate days of festivals, and since there is no Tziduk HaDin, there is no Kaddish.

The Ramban wrote that Tziduk HaDin is an acknowledgment and acceptance of divine judgment. Rabbi Isaac said it would be appropriate to recite it at the cemetery even when burying someone on a festival day—why should one not justify God's judgment on a festival as on a weekday? Regarding burial during the intermediate days of festivals, he wrote that he saw in the Machzor Vitry, compiled by his grandfather Rabbi Simcha (one of Rashi's students), that once it happened that people there were preventing the recitation of Tziduk HaDin, and Rashi stood up and recited Tziduk HaDin and Kaddish for him. See the Mordechai at the beginning of tractate Mo'ed Katan, and observe what the common practice is. I have already written my opinion on this in Chapter 29 of the second discourse.

I found support in the Jerusalem Talmud for the custom of reciting Tziduk HaDin at the grave of someone buried during the intermediate days of a festival or on a festival, as it states there: "Rabbi Abun died during the festival, and Rabbi Muna did not perform an act of kindness for him. He said, 'After the festival, we will honor him.'"

He also wrote that it is a widespread ruling that one buries the dead only in a tallit with

[i] The Ramban (Nachmanides) offers an important insight into the theological purpose of Tziduk HaDin—it is not merely a ritual formality but an act of spiritual acceptance and acknowledgment of divine justice. This understanding explains why there would be tension about whether it should be recited during joyous occasions like festivals.

כדמפורש במנחות[i] וגם שאבא
שאול במסכת שמחות צוה את
בניו שיקברוהו תחת מרגלותיו
של אביו ויתירו תכלת מפוליונו
מכל מקום מצינו שטוב לקשר
אותו ובזה אין צריך לחוש אם
הכתפים לובשים טלית בציצית
בעת נשיאתם אותו כאשר כתב
הרא״ש ומהרר״י קארו ובפרט
עתה שכל הקהל או רובם רוצים
לזכות במצות היה צריך להמתין
להסיר הציצית מבגד המת
סמוך לקבר ולא ראיתי נזהרין
מזה על כן טוב לקושרו יעיין
במרדכי דף רצ״א ע״א דברי
ר״י בזה ועיין במאמר ג׳ פי״ג
מה שהעלינו ברמז הטלית של
מתים. ובפרקי רבי אליעזר
אומר כל המתים עולים לתחית
המתים בתכריכיהן וכן אמרו
בפירוש בגמרין פרק אלו מגלחין
קל וחומר מחטה וכן למדנו
משמואל הנביא שנאמר זקן עולה
והוא עוטה מעיל ומעיל זה הוא
לבוש מיוחס לראוים לדבר
ברוח הקדש כאשר כתב הרמב״ם
בהלכות כלי המקדש והוא רמז
לחלוקא דרבנן כאשר כתב
הריקאנט״ו על פסוק ומעיל קטן
עשה לו אמו ובתשובת הגאונים
נראה שהתכריכין יהיו תפורים
בחוט של פשתן וכן כתב הרמב״ם
בהלכות אבל. שהפשתן נקרא
עץ יורה להנהגת עץ החיים
אפילו בסוד מלבושיו שהם
רמז לחלוקא דרבנן[ii] כנודע

tzitzit,[1] whether it is a new tallit or the deceased's own fringed tallit. The reason is to avoid "mocking the poor," as explained in tractate Menachot. And although Abba Shaul, in tractate Semachot, instructed his sons to bury him beneath his father's feet and to remove the blue threads from his garment, we find that it is good to tie them [rather than remove them completely]. In this way, there is no need to be concerned if the pallbearers wear a tallit with tzitzit while carrying the deceased, as written by the Rosh and Rabbi Joseph Karo. Especially now, when the entire congregation or most of them wish to participate in the mitzvah, one would need to wait to remove the tzitzit from the deceased's garment near the grave, and I have not seen people being careful about this. Therefore, it is good to tie them [rather than remove them]. See Mordechai, page 291a, for Rabbi Isaac's words on this matter, and see what we have suggested symbolically about the tallit of the deceased in Discourse 3, Chapter 13.

In Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer, it states that all the dead will rise at the resurrection of the dead in their shrouds, and this is explicitly stated in our Talmud in the chapter "Eilu Megalchin," using a kal vachomer (a fortiori) argument from wheat. We also learn this from the prophet Samuel, of whom it is said, "An old man is coming up, and he is wrapped in a robe." This robe is the distinguished garment worn by those worthy to speak with the Holy Spirit, as the Rambam wrote in the Laws of Temple Vessels, and it alludes to the "scholarly garment" (chaluka d'rabbanan)[2] as written by the Recanati on the verse, "And his mother made him a little robe." From the responsa of the Geonim, it appears that the shrouds should be sewn with linen

[1] This passage reveals an interesting ritual question: should the deceased be buried with tzitzit (ritual fringes) attached to their tallit (prayer shawl)? The concern stems from the principle of "loeg larash" (mocking the poor/deceased) by dressing them in garments intended for commandments they can no longer perform. The author describes different approaches to resolving this tension.

[2] Chaluka d'rabbanan (literally "rabbis' garment") is a kabbalistic concept referring to a spiritual garment formed from one's Torah study and good deeds that clothes the soul in the afterlife. This passage connects physical burial shrouds with their spiritual counterparts, suggesting that the material garments have mystical significance.

[i] The Talmudic concept of "loeg larash" (mocking the poor) is based on Proverbs 17:5 and refers to performing mitzvot (commandments) in front of the dead, who can no longer fulfill them. This creates a potential problem with burying someone in ritual garments they can no longer use properly.

[ii] This passage contains a fascinating kabbalistic interpretation that connects linen (called "wood"

ממעשה שהובא בירושלמי פ׳
הנושא מאותם שראו ארונו שהם
באין מחוצה לארץ ואמר רבי
אלעזר לרבי נתן קריא כיון
שמגיעין לארץ היו נוטלין גוש
עפר ומניחין על ארונו דכתיב
וכפר אדמתו עמו על זה כתבו
ההגהות מימוניות בסוף פרק
ה׳ מהלכות מלכים ומלחמות
ז״ל מכאן נראה סמך למה שנהגו
להניח עפר מארץ ישראל על
המתים אע״ג דהאי דירושלמי
איירי בארץ ישראל ע״כ וקבלתי
כי חלוקא דרבנן נעשה כמין
קומה שלמה וגדולה והולך לפני
הצדיקים ואולי זה סוד עמודא
דנורא ושוטיתיה דההוא סבא
בנודע:[ii] [i]

thread, and so wrote the Rambam in the Laws of Mourning. Linen, which is called "wood," teaches about the governance of the Tree of Life even in the mystery of its garments, which symbolize the scholarly garment, as is known from the story brought in the Jerusalem Talmud in the chapter "HaNose" about those who saw coffins coming from outside the Land of Israel. Rabbi Eleazar said to Rabbi Nathan, "When they reach the Land, they would take a clod of earth and place it on the coffin, as it is written, 'And His land will atone for His people.'" Regarding this, the Hagahot Maimoniyot wrote at the end of Chapter 5 of the Laws of Kings and Wars:[1] "From here there appears to be support for the custom of placing earth from the Land of Israel on the deceased, even though the Jerusalem Talmud is discussing [burials] in the Land of Israel." I have received a tradition that the scholarly garment takes the form of a complete and great stature, and walks before the righteous,[A] and perhaps this is the secret of the "pillar of fire and

105 105R 110 110R 115 115R 120R

[A] Or: "the chaluka d'rabbanan (scholarly garment) manifests as a complete divine structure and proceeds before the righteous" — The phrase 'קומה שלמה' has specific kabbalistic connotations referring to the complete divine structure or spiritual body. This alternative better captures the mystical significance while preserving the original technical term.

[1] Hagahot Maimoniyot (Maimonidean Glosses) is a medieval commentary on Maimonides' Mishneh Torah by Rabbi Meir HaKohen. The passage shows how later authorities found support for customs not explicitly mentioned in earlier sources, demonstrating the evolving nature of Jewish burial practices.

in Joshua 2:6) with the Tree of Life. The author suggests that even burial shrouds made of linen serve as a symbolic connection to eternal life and the spiritual garment (chaluka d'rabbanan) that the soul wears in the afterlife.

[i] This reference alludes to a famous Talmudic story (Bava Metzia 85b) about Rabbi Judah the Prince, where after his death a pillar of fire was seen accompanying him. The author suggests that this pillar may have been the visible manifestation of the spiritual "scholarly garment" (chaluka d'rabbanan) that precedes the righteous in the afterlife.

[ii] Cf. Zohar, Parashat Terumah — This reference establishes a kabbalistic understanding of the soul's ongoing existence after death and explains why certain prayers might be more appropriate at specific calendar times. The author is using this to ground the halakhic discussion in mystical concepts. | Cf. Tractate Mo'ed Katan — The reference is cited to support the ruling of the sages of Mainz who would recite Tziduk HaDin on festivals only for a great scholar, based on the principle that normal festival restrictions on mourning don't apply for a Torah scholar. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — This reference supports the custom of reciting Tziduk HaDin at the grave of someone buried during intermediate festival days, showing that certain mourning customs were practiced even during festivals. | Cf. Tractate Menachot — This reference explains why there's concern about burying someone in a tallit with tzitzit—because the deceased can no longer fulfill commandments, and it might seem like mockery to dress them in ritual garments they cannot use. | Cf. Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer — The reference supports the idea that the dead will rise at resurrection wearing the same shrouds in which they were buried, establishing a connection between burial practices and eschatological beliefs. | Cf. Machzor Vitry — This reference demonstrates the tension between different halakhic opinions and how Rashi resolved it in practice, showing that a great authority permitted reciting Tziduk HaDin even during festival periods.

the attendant of that Elder," as is known.[1]

פרק כ״ז

Chapter 27

ממה שאמר הכתוב ותמת שרה בקריית ארבע היא חברון שם הורה על תוספת מעלת שרה שהחזירה פקדונה במקום הקדושה שער גן עדן שהוא חברון והוא אחד מג׳ מקומות שנפדו בארץ ישראל בדמים קבורת חברון בד׳ מאות שקל כסף על ידי אברהם הב׳ חלקת השדה דשכם במאה קשיטה על ידי יעקב ובזמן הקנין ויבא שלם לא בעת המיתה כמערה שקנה אברהם. הג׳ גורן ארונה והקונה דוד ופדיונו בחמשים שקל כסף אמנם נתנם בזהב והיה על ידי דוד. ולא היה מלכות לישראל רק על ידי חברון ואין תורה לישראל אלא על ידי סוד החלקה זאת ששם הר גריזים ועיבל. ואין לישראל מקדש אלא מצד הגורן. ועפרון וחמור וארנן נמשלים לנחש שתפס ג׳ חלקים אלו הכוללים כל אושר האדם והם ג׳ חלקים א״י הגשמית המורה על הרוחנית וג׳ מקומות אלו מורים לג׳ חלקי נשמה רוח ונפש ולכן פדיונן ע״י אברהם יעקב דוד מוקבלים למרכבת כל אחד מהם[i] והדרוש

From the scriptural verse "And Sarah died in Kiryat Arba, which is Hebron" (Genesis 23:2), we learn of Sarah's elevated status, as she returned her soul in a holy place—the gateway to the Garden of Eden, which is Hebron.[2] This is one of three locations in the Land of Israel that were redeemed with money: first, the burial cave in Hebron for four hundred silver shekels by Abraham; second, the plot of land in Shechem for one hundred kesitah by Jacob, purchased when he arrived whole (Genesis 33:18), not at the time of death as with the cave Abraham bought; third, the threshing floor of Araunah, purchased by David for fifty silver shekels, though he paid in gold. Israel's monarchy was established only through Hebron, the Torah came to Israel only through the mystery of this plot where Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal stand, and Israel received its Temple only through the threshing floor. Ephron, Hamor, and Araunah are comparable to the serpent[3] who seized these three portions that encompass all human wellbeing. These three locations correspond to the physical Land of Israel, which indicates the spiritual realm, and to the three components of the soul: neshamah, ruach, and nefesh.[4] Their redemption by Abraham, Jacob, and David corresponds to the divine chariot associated with each of them. This subject is extensive in its place, and there is significance to the redemption amount for each when you examine it closely.

[1] This refers to a famous Talmudic account (Bava Metzia 85b) describing a pillar of fire that appeared at Rabbi Judah the Prince's funeral. The author suggests this visible phenomenon might actually represent the spiritual "scholarly garment" that accompanies the righteous after death, connecting a mystical concept with a physical manifestation recorded in rabbinic literature.

[2] In kabbalistic tradition, certain physical locations are understood as entry points to spiritual realms. Hebron is associated with the Cave of Machpelah where the patriarchs are buried, and is considered a gateway to Gan Eden (Paradise).

[3] These three biblical figures sold sacred land to the patriarchs. The comparison to the serpent (nachash) from the Garden of Eden story suggests they represented negative spiritual forces that had seized control of holy places which needed to be redeemed by righteous individuals.

[4] These are the three primary components of the soul in Kabbalistic thought. Neshamah is the highest, most divine aspect; ruach is the middle component associated with emotion and spirit; nefesh is the lowest aspect connected to vitality and physical life.

[i] The author connects the three patriarchs (Abraham, Jacob, and David) with the concept of the divine chariot (merkavah). In Kabbalistic thought, these biblical figures are not merely historical personages but correspond to different divine attributes (sefirot) and serve as 'chariots' or vehicles for divine presence in the world.

רחב במקומו ויש טעם למספר
הפדיון לכל אחד כשתעיין בו.
ומצאתי כתוב בדברי החכם
קורדואי״רו זצ״ל שאין ספק
ששם בחברון היה מיתת האדם
בחכמתו הגדולה וצוה ליקבר
שם כדפירשו בזהר ומזה נראה
ודאי שמקום הקבורה והמיתה
יגרום חלק מה לשרות שכינה
בשיתוף סילוק הנשמה על פי ה׳
כפי ענין קדושת המקום ששכינה
שורה בו[i] לכן התאזרנו עז
להזהיר גם בני אדם גם בני איש
לקדש מקום מעמד הנפטר בשפת
אמת. ואפילו בארץ ישראל יש
חילוק בין מקום למקום כאמרם
רגלוהי דבר אינש אינון ערבין
ביה וכן עבדי שלמה ששלחם
ללוז. שים נא עיניך בילמדנו
פ׳ פקודי דף מ״ט ע״ב כי על
פסוק ויורני ויאמר לי כתב כל
מה שעושה המלאך עם הנשמה
קודם בואה לעולם ובפרט
אמר שמטייל אותה מהבקר עד
הערב ומראה לו מקום שעתיד
למות בו ומקום שעתיד ליקבר
בו. ובויקרא דף נ״ב ע״ב אמר
כי נשמת הרשעים אינה עולה
למקום שנגזר שם עד י״ב חדש
שיכלה הגוף מה עושה הולכת
וחוזרת על הקבר וקשה עליה
ראיית הגוף נרקב למה״ד וכו׳
וכן הרוח שוטט בעולם וחוזר
לקבר והנפש מתאבלת עליו.

I found written in the works of the sage Rabbi Moses Cordovero, may his righteous memory be blessed, that without doubt Adam died in Hebron with his great wisdom and commanded to be buried there, as explained in the Zohar. From this it is certainly evident that the location of burial and death contributes in some measure to the presence of the Divine Presence, in conjunction with the departure of the soul by God's command, according to the sanctity of the place where the Divine Presence dwells. Therefore, we have strengthened our resolve to warn both common and distinguished people to sanctify the place where the deceased stands with truthful speech. Even within the Land of Israel, there are distinctions between places, as they say, "A person's feet are his guarantors,"[A] as with Solomon's servants whom he sent to Luz.[1]

Consider what is written in Yalkut Pekudei, page 49b, on the verse "He instructed me and said to me" (Proverbs 4:4): it describes everything the angel does with the soul before it comes into the world, particularly stating that the angel walks with it from morning until evening,[2] showing it the place where it is destined to die and the place where it is destined to be buried. And in Leviticus, page 52b, it states that the souls of the wicked do not ascend to their destined place until twelve months after the body has decomposed. What does it do? It goes back and forth to the grave, and it is difficult for it to see the body decaying, like the parable, etc. Similarly, the spirit wanders in the world and returns to the grave, and the nefesh (vital soul) mourns over it.

From the story in Tractate Yoma about Kidor's father, who appeared to Kidor in a dream saying,

[A] Or: "A person's feet lead him to his destined place" — This Aramaic phrase appears in Talmudic literature with a nuanced meaning that a person's feet will naturally lead them to their destined location or fate. The alternate translation better captures this concept of divine providence guiding one's physical movements.

[1] This refers to a rabbinic tradition that Luz was a city where the Angel of Death had no power, and where Solomon sent his servants who feared death. The reference supports the idea that different locations have different spiritual qualities.

[2] This describes the soul's pre-birth experience, where an angel shows it both the place where it will die and be buried. This kabbalistic concept emphasizes that a person's death location is preordained and has spiritual significance.

[i] This reveals a fundamental principle in Ma'avar Yabok: the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) dwells in particular locations, and dying in such places facilitates the soul's ascent. This connects to the rabbinic teaching that some locations, like Jerusalem or Hebron, have special sanctity that affects spiritual processes.

וממעשה שהובא ביומא פרק
יום הכפורים מאבוהי דכידור
דאתחזי לכידור בחלמיה ואמר
תא שקיל כיסא דמנח ברישא
דההוא גברא נראה שהרשעים
אפילו בפתחה של גיהנם אינם
שבים הגם שנוכל לומר שהיה
מקפיד שלא יהיה דבר אחר
בתוך קברו ועל ראשו וממה
שהובא במסכת בתרא ממעשה
דרבי בנאה דהוה מציין מערתא
וחזא אליעזר עבד אברהם דקאי
אבבא (שהוא במדרגת מטטרון
ולכן נקרא עבד)[i] משם נראה כי
אשרי המשמש אדם גדול בעה״ז
שכן זוכה לשמשו בעולם הבא
וכמעשה דאותו תלמיד של רבי
אליעזר שאמרו הניחו לו שאדם
גדול שימש. הנה גם שלמעלה
בפרק ט״ו ממאמר ב׳ חזרתי
למצוא סמך מדברי הזהר על
מנהג המסלקים מחדר הגוסס
קרוביו הבוכים הוא דוקא כדי
שלא לצערו בהרמת קולם כי אז
עת לחשות מבכי שלא להטריד
כוונת הזוכה לקדש עצמו אז
כשרפים אבל אם היו יכולים
לעמוד על עמדם בלא דלויי קול
אין ספק שיש תענוג למת בחיות
קרוביו החיים שם בעת סילוק
נשמתו כמו שמענג מקריבוהי
ומרחימוהי המתים בנזבר בזהר
פ׳ ויחי והעד על זה מאמר
הכתוב ויוסף ישית ידו על עיניך

"Come take the purse that rests at the head of that man," it appears that the wicked do not repent even at the entrance to Gehenna—although we could say he was merely being particular that nothing else should be inside his grave or on his head. And from what is brought in Tractate Bava Batra about Rabbi Banah who was marking graves and saw Eliezer, Abraham's servant, standing at the entrance (who was at the level of Metatron and therefore called "servant"), we see how fortunate is one who serves a great person in this world, for he merits to serve him in the World to Come, as in the case of that student of Rabbi Eliezer, about whom they said, "Leave him be, for he served a great man."

Although earlier in chapter 15 of the second discourse, I found support in the Zohar for the custom of removing crying relatives from the room of a dying person, this is specifically to avoid distressing them with raised voices, for then is a time to refrain from weeping[1] so as not to disturb the intention of one who merits to sanctify himself like the seraphim.[A] But if they could stand their ground without raising their voices,[B] there is no doubt that the deceased derives pleasure from having living relatives present at the time of his soul's departure, just as he enjoys the presence of his deceased relatives and loved ones, as mentioned in the Zohar, Parashat Vayechi. The evidence for this is the verse "And Joseph shall place his hand upon your eyes" (Genesis 46:4). It is not satisfactory to say this refers merely to physical resemblance or physical pleasure, as the masses might think, for Jacob the pious one would not have been given good tidings about such a trivial matter. However, if a son is present for his father at the time

[A] Or: "like the burning angels" — The Hebrew word 'seraphim' derives from the root 'to burn,' and these angels are often characterized by their fiery nature. This alternate translation would be more explanatory for readers unfamiliar with angelic categories, though less precise as a technical term.

[B] Or: "without lifting up their voices in lamentation" — The Hebrew phrase refers specifically to the raising of voices in mourning or lamentation, rather than simply speaking loudly. This alternate translation better captures the ritual context of formal mourning expressions.

[1] This alludes to Ecclesiastes 3:4, "A time to weep and a time to laugh; a time to mourn and a time to dance," suggesting that while mourning is appropriate after death, the moment of transition itself requires silence and focus.

[i] This parenthetical comment reveals a sophisticated kabbalistic understanding of Eliezer, Abraham's servant. By associating him with the angel Metatron (who in Jewish mysticism was once the human Enoch), the text suggests that righteous servants can attain angelic status after death and continue their service in the spiritual realm.

ולא ניחא לומר שיהיה דמיון
גשמי והנאה גשמית כדעת החמון
שלא על דבר קל זה יתבשר
יעקב החסיד. אמנם אם הוא בן
לגבי אביו בעת סלוק הנשמה
והרוח והנפש. והנפש הגשמית.
מידי רכיבתם על ענפיהם שבכח
הבן יהיה בזה בלי ספק מעלה
אל האב מצד הבן מפני שהאב
רוכב על בניו כענין יעקב
על י״ב שבטים וכן הרב על
תלמידיו[i] שע״כ אמר רבי יוסף
חפני ושמעון אפרתי הם שמשוני
בחיי וכו׳ כדהוו סברי רבנן
כנזכר שם:[ii]

when the neshamah, ruach, nefesh, and the physical soul depart from their branches, the son's presence undoubtedly elevates the father through the son, because the father rides upon his children, just as Jacob rode upon the twelve tribes, and as a teacher upon his students. This is why Rabbi Joseph Chofni and Shimon Efrati, who served Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi in his lifetime, were considered as the rabbis thought, as mentioned there.

פרק כ״ח

Chapter 28

זכינו בזה לדעת שבהיות הבן
עומד על אביו בעת פטירתו זה
יהיה חסד האב עם הבן והבן עם
האב[iii] האב מנחיל לבן העה״ז
הגשמי למעשה המצות וזה יהיה
סוד המנהג הברכה מאב לבן
בפרט בשעת מיתה כדאמרו
בילמדנו אתה מוצא שהצדיקים
מברכין לבניהם בשעת מיתתן
ובירושה המנחיל לו מעמידו
על רגליו וסבותיו לכוין מעשיו
לתקון גבוה שלכן נקרא הממון
יקום[iv] והבן מעלה האב על שכמו

Through this we have learned that when a son stands by his father at the time of his death, this constitutes an act of loving-kindness between father and son, each to the other. The father bequeaths to his son the physical world for the performance of commandments, and this explains the custom of a father blessing his son, particularly at the time of death, as stated in Yelamdeinu: "You find that the righteous bless their children at the time of their death." Through inheritance, the father establishes his son and provides the means for him to direct his actions toward higher spiritual rectification; this is why wealth is called "substance" (yekum). The

[i] This metaphor of 'riding upon' children or students reflects a kabbalistic concept where the teacher or parent's spiritual essence continues through and is elevated by their disciples or children. This explains why having children or students present at death is spiritually beneficial for the departed soul.

[ii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 15 — The author references his earlier discussion about removing crying relatives from the deathbed, now qualifying that this is only necessary if they cannot control their voices. This shows the text's consistent concern with creating proper spiritual conditions for the dying person. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Vayechi — The author cites the Zohar to support the claim that the deceased derives pleasure from the presence of loved ones, establishing a mystical connection between the living and the dead that is central to Ma'avar Yabok's theology of death rituals. | Cf. Tractate Yoma — The author uses this Talmudic story to illustrate that the wicked remain connected to physical concerns even after death, reinforcing the book's theme that one's character and behavior in life affects one's experience after death. | Cf. Works of Rabbi Moses Cordovero — The citation of Cordovero (one of the most important kabbalists) establishes the author's intellectual lineage within Kabbalah and supports the claim about sacred burial locations, connecting Adam's burial to the same location as the Patriarchs.

[iii] The text presents a reciprocal relationship of chesed (loving-kindness) between father and son that extends beyond death, establishing a theological framework for inheritance laws and burial customs.

[iv] The Hebrew term 'yekum' (substance/that which stands) is used as a wordplay on the purpose of

למעלה עטרה להתעטר בעולם
העליון במעשיו הטובים[i] וזהו
צוואת יעקב לבניו בנשיאת
מטתו ומנהג התלמידים הנושאים
מטת רבן. ממה שאמר הכתוב
באברהם יצחק ויעקב כי קברו
אותם בניהם נראה כי נייחא
גדולה יהיה לאב בעת שבניו
יעסקו בקבורתו וגם כן ודאי
יהיה זכות והנאה לבן בחייו
ובמותו ולא לחנם מנהגן של
ישראל להקפיד על זה קפידה
גדולה ומחולי יעקב וצוואת בניו
ופרטי קבורתו ובמלוים אותו
והאבל כבד שעשו בעבורו משם
יש למשכיל לדרוש ולהבין כמה
פרטים בבקור חולים ובהלואת
המת וקבורתו ובביתו ואבלותם
עליו ובעסיקת הבן בצרכי
קבורת אביו משם יהיה לבן זכות
אבות ואור מתנוצץ לו ממנו וזה
טעם הירושה לקרובים ואיסור
העברת נחלה בנזכר בגמרא
אפילו מברא בישא לטבא. וכתב
המגיה בסוף סי׳ רנ״ב בחשן
המשפט זה לשונו מי שהפקיד
מעות אצל חברו ואומר שאם
ימות יעשה בהם המוטב יתנו
ליורשיו והירושה תלויה בבחינת
נפש האב לבן והקונה הנשמה
קונה הירושה[ii] ואם זכית לידע
טעם למה היו נכסי הגר בנעני
שמת כל הקודם בהם זכה תבין
למה ישראל עשו מצרים במצולה
שאין בה דגים ופירוש ואחרי כן
יצאו ברכוש גדול ולמה לא זכו

son, in turn, elevates his father, carrying him on his shoulders as a crown to be adorned in the upper world through his good deeds. This explains Jacob's instructions to his sons regarding the bearing of his bier, and the custom of disciples carrying their teacher's bier. 15R

From what Scripture says about Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob—that their sons buried them—it appears that a father derives great comfort when his sons attend to his burial. This certainly also benefits the son, both in his lifetime and after his death. It is not without reason that Jewish custom is so particular about this matter. From Jacob's illness, his instructions to his sons, the details of his burial, those who accompanied him, and the heavy mourning they observed for him, a discerning person can derive and understand many principles regarding visiting the sick, accompanying the dead, burial practi[1]ces, weeping and mourning for the deceased, and a son's involvement in his father's burial arrangements. Through this, the son gains ancestral merit[2] and a radiant light shines upon him. This explains the law of inheritance to relatives and the prohibition against transferring inheritance, as mentioned in the Talmud: "Even from a bad son to a good one." 20R 25R 30R 35R

The commentator wrote at the end of section 252 in Choshen Mishpat: "One who deposits money with another and says that if he dies, the recipient should do what is best with it—it should be given to his heirs. Inheritance depends on the connection between the father's soul and the son's, and one who acquires the soul acquires the inheritance. If you have merited to understand why the property of a deceased convert or Canaanite belongs to whoever claims it first,[3] you will understand why Israel emp- 40R 45R

[1]The Hebrew term 'halvayat ha-met' specifically refers to the Jewish practice of escorting the deceased to burial, considered one of the highest forms of chesed (loving-kindness) because it cannot be reciprocated.

[2]The concept of 'zechut avot' (ancestral merit) is a significant theological principle in Judaism, suggesting that righteous actions of ancestors create spiritual benefits for descendants, and conversely, descendants' actions can elevate their ancestors' souls.

[3]This refers to the halakhic principle that a convert who dies without Jewish descendants has no inheritance—to establish the son and enable him to 'stand' spiritually through the father's legacy.

[i]This reflects the kabbalistic concept that children's good deeds create a 'crown' for their parents in the afterlife, elevating their spiritual status.

[ii]This cryptic phrase suggests that inheritance has a spiritual dimension beyond mere property transfer—one who has a soul connection to the deceased (typically a son) is the appropriate inheritor of their legacy.

ישראל לששים רבוא רק במצרים
ומה היה כוונת יוסף לדון בין
המצריים על העריות וביוצא
מז׳ מצות ותבין כי יציאת מצרים
הכרח לבריאת העולם מפני
שעל ידי זה נתקן ובן מצינו
כי היורש הוא חייב להשתדל
לנייחת נפש מורישו שבנרצח
אמרו אבל הראוי לירושה הוא
גואל הדם ונפסק ההלכה בדברי
הרמב״ם ריש פרק קמא מהלכות
רוצח שהיה מצוה ביד גואל הדם
להמית הרוצח שנאמר גואל הדם
הוא ימית את הרוצח וכבר כתבנו
במאמר ב׳ שבהריגת הרוצח עשה
נייחא לנרצח[i] וכל שכן שהיה
חייב לבזבז ממון לעשות לו
נייחא ולבער המזיק אם אחד
היה ולטעם הנזכר נשתנה הרוצח
משאר חייבי מיתות ב״ד אם ברח
לב״ד אחר כל מקום שעמדו
שנים ואמרו שנגמר דינו בבית
דין פלוני נהרג ובשאר היה
צריך שיבואו עדיו הראשוני׳
דוקא כדאמרי׳ בסוף פרק קמא
דמכות. עוד אמרינן בפרק
לגמר הדין שאם עמד הנידון
על נפשו לא היה רשות לשאר
העם להורגו רק לעדיו והרוצח
היו רודפיו אחריו בכל דבר
וביד כל אדם עד שהיו ממיתין
אותו ממה שאמרו שם בגמרא
שאין קוברין אבן הנסקל וסייף
הנהרג בקברו רק בתפיסתו יש
ללמוד שמרחיקין כל מזיק מקבר
המת[ii] וכבר ביארנו למה אין
קוברין רשע אצל צדיק במאמר
ב׳ ועיין מה שכתבנו מהרוצח

tied Egypt like a pool without fish, and the meaning of 'afterward they went out with great possessions.' And why Israel only attained the number of six hundred thousand in Egypt, and what was Joseph's intention in judging the Egyptians regarding forbidden relationships and other of the seven Noahide commandments. You will understand that the Exodus from Egypt was necessary for the creation of the world, because through it the world was rectified."

We also find that an heir is obligated to strive for the repose of the soul of the one who bequeathed to him. Regarding a murder victim, they said that the one entitled to the inheritance is the blood redeemer.[1] The law was established in the words of Maimonides at the beginning of the first chapter of the Laws of Murder, that it was a commandment for the blood redeemer to execute the murderer, as it is said, "The blood redeemer shall put the murderer to death." We have already written in the second discourse that by killing the murderer, one brings repose to the victim, and certainly one would be obligated to spend money to bring him repose and to eliminate the harmful person if there was one.

For the reason mentioned, a murderer differs from other people sentenced to death by the court: if he fled to another court, wherever two witnesses stood and testified that his judgment was concluded in a certain court, he would be executed. In other cases, it was necessary for the original witnesses themselves to come, as we say at the end of the first chapter of Makkot. We also say in the chapter on concluding judgment that if the condemned person defended himself, the general populace had no authority to kill him, only his witnesses could do so; but in the case of a murderer, his pursuers would chase him in every way, and any person had the right to execute him.

From what the Talmud says there—that the stone used for stoning and the sword used for beheading

inheritance relationship, so their property becomes ownerless and available to the first claimant. The author uses this to explain the spiritual principle behind the Israelites taking property from Egypt during the Exodus.

[1] The 'goel ha-dam' (blood redeemer) in biblical law was the nearest relative of a murder victim, who had both the right and duty to avenge the death by killing the murderer. The author connects this to inheritance law, suggesting that the same spiritual connection that qualifies one as an heir also creates the obligation to bring justice and rest to the deceased's soul.

[i] The author posits that executing a murderer brings spiritual rest (neicha) to the victim's soul, providing a mystical justification for capital punishment beyond mere retribution or deterrence.

[ii] This principle explains various burial customs that involve separating harmful or negative elements from the deceased, based on the belief that such elements could disturb the soul's rest.

בחלק עתר ענן הקטרת. ולהיות
נשיאת המת על הכתף לעטר
אותו בעולם העליון במעשיו
הטובים כנזכר בזה נבין למה
צריך לעמוד בפני המת העובר
ולמה היה בר נדוי למי שאינו
מלוה המת כשרואה אותו עובר
לפחות ד׳ אמות כדפסק מהרר״י
קארו בסוף סימן שס״א. וגם
זכינו לטעם ומנהג המקומות
שלוקחים האבלים והקרובים
המטה על כתפיהם ואחר כך
שאר העם באשר כתב המגיה
בסי׳ שנ״ז ואין ספק שיש לאשה
תועלת בהיות בעלה שם בסלוק
נשמתה וגם בבניה שיש לה יחס
גדול עם בניה וכל שכן עם בעלה
כי דו פרצופין נבראו ואחר כך
ננסרו בהיכל לבנת הספיר[i] ומה
גם סוד חלק הבעל הנקשר עמה
על הדרך שפירשו בסבא פוק
חזי תמן ובפרט כל עוד שלא
נשאת[ii] ומטעם תועלת המת בעת
המתנתה אליו תקנו כי אלמנה
ניזונת מנכסי בעלה ומשתמשת
במדור ובכרים ובכסתות וכלים
שנשתמשה בהן בחיי בעלה ולסוד
החלק המיוחד הזה שביניהם
בעת סלוקה בחיי בעלה במעמד
בעלה תקבל הנאה גדולה מזה
הנה פסקו הפוסקים כי יכולים
לחלל שבת לשלוח אחר קרוביו
של חולה ומלבד שעקר הטעם
שלא תטרף דעתו עליו אפשר
שקצת מהם כוונו גם כן למה
שאמרנו:[iii]

are not buried with the executed person in his grave but only in the place of detention—we learn that all harmful things are kept far from the grave of the dead. We have already explained why a wicked person is not buried next to a righteous one in the second discourse. See also what we wrote about the murderer in the section "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (The Cloud of Incense Prayer). 90R 95R

Understanding that carrying the deceased on one's shoulder serves to crown him in the upper world with his good deeds, as mentioned, we can understand why one must stand before a passing corpse, and why one who does not accompany the dead when seeing them pass by at least four cubits is subject to excommunication,[1] as Rabbi Joseph Karo ruled at the end of section 361. We have also learned the reason for the custom in some places where the mourners and relatives take the bier on their shoulders, and afterward the rest of the people, as the commentator wrote in section 357. 100R 105R

There is no doubt that it benefits a woman to have her husband present when her soul departs, and likewise her children, as she has a great relationship with her children and especially with her husband, for they were created as a dual-faced being and were later separated in the Palace of the Sapphire Brick.[2] This is particularly true regarding the secret of the husband's portion that is bound with her, as explained in the Saba section—go and see there—especially as long as she has not remarried. 110R 115R

Because of the benefit to the deceased during the time of waiting for him, they instituted that a widow is sustained from her husband's property and may use the dwelling, pillows, blankets, and vessels that she used during her husband's lifetime. Due to this special connection between them, at the time of her 120R

[1] The text references the serious religious obligation to show respect to the dead by accompanying the funeral procession at least four cubits (approximately 6-8 feet). Failing to do so was considered so serious that it could result in nidui (excommunication).

[2] Heikhal Livnat HaSapir is a kabbalistic term referring to a celestial realm where souls and divine emanations interact. The author uses this mystical concept to explain the spiritual connection between husband and wife that persists even after death.

[i] This references the kabbalistic concept that Adam and Eve were originally created as a single dual-faced being and later separated. 'The Palace of the Sapphire Brick' (Heikhal Livnat HaSapir) is a mystical realm where divine unifications occur. The author applies this concept to all married couples.

[ii] This refers to the principle that a spiritual connection remains between husband and wife as long as the widow has not remarried, creating special obligations but also spiritual benefits.

[iii] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2 — The author refers back to his earlier discussion to establish

departure during her husband's lifetime, in the presence of her husband, she receives great benefit from this. Thus, the legal authorities ruled that one may violate the Sabbath to send for relatives of a sick person.[1] Apart from the main reason being so that the sick person's mind not become distressed, it is possible that some of them also intended what we have mentioned.

פרק כ״ט

Chapter 29

ממצות כסוי הדם מחיות ועופות המותרים לאכול ושצריך עפר למטה ולמעלה נבין ג״כ טעם הקבורה כי דם הוא סוד הברית[i] כי ע״י היות דם יוצא הברית מתקיים והוא בין עפר עליון בינה לתחתון מלכות[ii] ולכן העפר מוליד ומהוה תולדות ובינה ומלכות הם ב׳ בריכות בריכה עליונה ותחתונה ואין ליהנות מפנימיות כל חי וזה טעם אסור אכילת הדם וכסויו ג״כ ולכן צריך לכסות המקומות ההם בסוד עפר למעלה ועפר למטה כי

From the commandment of covering the blood of permissible wild animals and birds that one may eat, and the requirement for earth below and above, we can also understand the reason for burial. For blood represents the mystery of the covenant,[A] since through the shedding of blood the covenant is established. This covenant exists between the upper earth (Binah) and the lower earth (Malkhut). Therefore, earth generates and produces offspring, and Binah and Malkhut are two pools—an upper pool and a lower pool. One should not derive benefit from the inner essence of any living being, which explains the prohibition against consuming blood and the requirement to cover it. Thus, one must cover these places with the mystical "earth above and earth below," for

[A] Or: "For blood is the secret of the covenant" — The Hebrew word 'סוד' (sod) can be translated as either 'mystery' or 'secret.' The latter might better convey the esoteric nature of the kabbalistic teaching being presented.

[1] This refers to the halakhic principle that saving a life (pikuach nefesh) overrides Sabbath prohibitions. The author extends this to include the psychological wellbeing of the sick person through having relatives present, and suggests a deeper mystical benefit to the sick person's soul.

continuity in his theological framework that connects ritual practices with spiritual benefits for the deceased. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, 'Eter Anan HaKetoret' section — The author directs readers to another section of his work for more detailed information, indicating the interconnected nature of his theological system across the entire book. | Cf. Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Laws of Murder, Chapter 1 — The author cites this authoritative legal source to ground his mystical interpretations in established halakhic tradition, showing how legal and mystical frameworks can complement each other. | Cf. Talmud, Tractate Makkot, end of Chapter 1 — The author uses this reference to highlight the unique severity with which Jewish law treats murder, supporting his argument about the special spiritual damage caused by murder and the corresponding need for rectification. | Cf. Zohar, Saba d'Mishpatim section — The author references this kabbalistic source to provide deeper understanding of why a husband's presence at his wife's deathbed would be spiritually beneficial for her soul's journey.

[i] The mystical significance of blood as representing the covenant (brit) is a fundamental kabbalistic concept. Here, the author draws on traditions that view blood as the physical manifestation of the soul's life-force, creating a link between ritual slaughter, blood coverage, and human burial.

[ii] The author employs the kabbalistic correspondence between Binah (Understanding, the eighth sefirah) and Malkhut (Kingdom, the tenth sefirah), characterizing them as 'upper earth' and 'lower earth' respectively. This relationship forms a fundamental axis in the kabbalistic system, with Binah representing the higher feminine principle and Malkhut the lower feminine principle.

בזה מתעלמי׳ ונסתרים ואין
החצוני שולט ופוגם[i] וחיה ועוף
עקריים בזה שרומזים בסוד
עליון ושאר הדם אף אם ישלטו
בו אינם פוגמים למעלה. ברם
קבורת גוף האדם מסייע ליחוד
עליון בנשמתו וזהו כי קבור
תקברנו[ii] קבור למעלה תקברנו
למטה כמו שהגוף נכנס אל
הקבר כן הנפש תכנס אל הלבוש
השני המזדמן לה זה מתלבש
בעפר תחתון ומתכפר וזה
מתלבש בעפר עליון ואין הנשמה
מתקבלת למעלה אל היחוד עד
שיקבר למטה וכמו שהוא אדם
נכנס בעפר דהיינו זכר בתוך
נקבה כן הנשמה למעלה מתקבל׳
כעין זכר בתוך נקבה וכבר
כתבנו כי המלכות מתעלם עם
הצדיק בסלוק נשמתו ולכן נקרא
יומא דהלולא דעילאי[iii] באומרם
עליוני׳ מבקשי׳ את רבי כי הנפש
דבק בגוף והנפש ברוח והרוח
בנשמה ונשמה בקדושה עליונה
ומדור הנפשות הוא עולם ובחינה
שכנגד הקבר ממש ונקרא חצר
מות[iv] בעובדא דשמואל דאזל
לחצר מות ולכן מרע״ה אם היה
קבור בא״י לא ישתתף עם דור
המדבר שמתו חוצה לה ויחסר

through this they are concealed and hidden, preventing external forces from controlling and damaging them. Wild animals and birds are essential in this regard, as they symbolize supernal mysteries, while other blood, even if external forces gain control over it, does not cause damage to the higher realms. 20R

However, the burial of a human body assists in the supernal unification of the soul, which is the meaning of "you shall surely bury him"—bury him above, bury him below. Just as the body enters the grave, so does the soul enter the second garment prepared for it. The body clothes itself in the lower earth and receives atonement, while the soul clothes itself in the upper earth. The soul is not received above for unification[A] until the body is buried below. And just as a person enters the earth—that is, as the masculine enters the feminine[B]—so too is the soul received above as the masculine within the feminine. 25R 30R

We have already written that Malkhut (Divine Kingdom) is concealed with the righteous person at the departure of his soul,[C] which is why it is called "the wedding day of the supernal ones," as they say, "The celestial beings desire Rabbi [Judah the Prince]." For the nefesh (vital soul) clings to the body, the nefesh to the ruach (spirit), the ruach to the neshamah (higher soul), and the neshamah to the supernal holiness. The dwelling place of souls is a world and dimension that truly corresponds to the grave, and is called "the Court of Death," as in the 35R 40R 45R

[A] Or: "The soul cannot be accepted above for the divine union" — This alternate translation emphasizes the mystical concept of 'יחוד' (yichud) as specifically referring to divine union rather than the more general term 'unification,' which might better convey the kabbalistic significance.

[B] Or: "the male within the female" — This alternate translation maintains the gender binary terminology more literally, which may be preferred in certain scholarly contexts where precise reflection of kabbalistic gender concepts is desired.

[C] Or: "Malkhut ascends with the righteous person when his soul departs" — The verb 'מתעלם' can mean both 'concealed' and 'ascends/elevates.' The latter may better convey the active upward movement that the author is describing in the soul's journey.

[i] The term החצוני (ha-chitzoni, 'the external forces') refers to negative spiritual entities that, according to kabbalistic thought, seek to draw power from holy sources. The covering of blood prevents these forces from accessing its spiritual potency.

[ii] This is a quote from Deuteronomy 21:23, which commands the burial of an executed person before nightfall. The author interprets the doubled language ('bury you shall bury him') as indicating both physical burial below and spiritual elevation above.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase meaning 'wedding day of the supernal ones' is traditionally used in Jewish mysticism to refer to the day of a righteous person's death. It reframes death not as an ending but as a mystical marriage between the soul and divine realms.

[iv] The 'Court of Death' (חצר מות) is a mystical concept referring to a spiritual realm where souls dwell after death. The reference to Samuel relates to the biblical account in 1 Samuel 28 where the prophet's spirit is summoned from the realm of the dead.

להם השלימות ההוא ומעיינות החכמה שנפתחים להם על ידי מרע״ה והוא אומרם לאהרן ואהרן לשאר רישי מתיבתי כדפירשו בזהר פ׳ בלק לכן רצה הקדוש ברוך הוא שישאר הרועה עם צאנו ויהיו מובטחים שיכנסו אחר התחיה יחד: [i]

account of Samuel who went to the Court of Death.

Therefore, if Moses our Teacher had been buried in the Land of Israel, he would not have been able to join with the generation of the wilderness who died outside it, and they would have lacked that perfection and the wellsprings of wisdom that are opened to them through Moses our Teacher. This is what they meant when they said that he speaks to Aaron, and Aaron to the other heads of the academies, as explained in the Zohar, Parashat Balak. Therefore, the Holy One, blessed be He, desired that the shepherd remain with his flock, so they would be assured of entering together after the resurrection.

פרק ל׳

Chapter 30

הגם שאמרו בגמרין שמי שעושה דבר של רשות במקום שלא נהגו נקרא טועה וזהן דברי רב יוסף נגד רב אויא דעבד לאתתיה מעמד ומושב ואומר שטעה בתרין. [ii] אם יעלה על

Although they said in the Gemara that one who does something optional[A] in a place where it is not customary is called mistaken—these being the words of Rav Yosef against Rav Avia[1] who made a standing and sitting ceremony[B] for his wife,[2] saying that he erred in two ways[C]—if someone should consider per-

[A] Or: "a discretionary matter" — The Hebrew phrase 'davar shel reshut' specifically refers to actions that are neither required nor forbidden by Jewish law. 'Discretionary matter' might better capture this technical legal concept than 'optional,' which could imply something trivial.

[B] Or: "the ceremony of standings and sittings" — This alternate translation more explicitly indicates the plural nature of the ritual, which involved multiple acts of standing and sitting in succession as part of the mourning ceremony.

[C] Or: "and he said that he erred in two respects" — The Aramaic word 'b'tarein' specifically means 'in two' or 'in two respects.' This alternate translation more clearly indicates that there were two specific errors identified, though the original translation adequately conveys the meaning.

[1] The original text has 'Rav Avia' (רב אויא) which might be a variant spelling of 'Rav Avya' or possibly a different sage altogether. I've maintained the spelling as closely as possible to the original while transliterating.

[2] The phrase 'maamad u'moshav' refers to a specific mourning ritual that involved participants standing and sitting multiple times as part of honoring the deceased. This practice appears to have varied by location in Talmudic times.

[i] Cf. Talmud Chullin 83b — The author uses this halakhic requirement as a mystical metaphor for burial practices, drawing a parallel between covering animal blood and human burial, both of which involve earth above and below. | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Balak — The author cites this to explain why Moses needed to be buried outside the Land of Israel with the generation of the wilderness, facilitating his ongoing spiritual connection with them. | Cf. Talmud Bava Metzia 85b — The author references this in explaining the phrase 'wedding day of the supernal ones' (יומא דהלולא דעילאי), suggesting that the death of a righteous person represents a cosmic unification. | Cf. 1 Samuel 28 — The author refers to this as evidence that souls dwell in a realm corresponding to their burial place, called 'the Court of Death' (חצר מות). | Cf. Deuteronomy 21:23 — The author interprets this verse mystically as indicating both physical burial below and spiritual elevation above, creating a correspondence between bodily interment and soul ascension.

[ii] This refers to a Talmudic passage (likely in Moed Katan) where Rav Yosef criticized Rav Avia for performing mourning ceremonies for his wife that were not customary in that location. The phrase 'maamad u'moshav' (standing and sitting) refers to specific mourning rituals where mourners would stand and sit multiple times to honor the deceased.

לב איזה פרטי לעשות ההקפות
למתו לא יקרא דבר הרשות
כי אם דבר מצוה ליודע טעמם
בסוד ההקפות והעד כבוש
ירי[i]חו והקפת המזבח בימי
הקרבת ע׳ פרים בחג[ii] עם
נוסח שירים החלוקים הנאמרים
בימי החג כגון מי יקום לי
עם מרעים[iii] כדאיתא בסוכה
פרק החליל ואמרו בירושלמי
דסוכה בזמן הזה חזן הכנסת
עומד כמלאך אלהים וספר
תורה בזרועו והעם מקיפין
אותו דוגמת המזבח וכבר אמרנו
במאמר ג׳ דבאתר דליכא
למיחש לאנצויי טוב להרגיל
אותם ואז תשמח נפש הנפטר
בסוד מחול וסבובים אלו
ויאירו עליו מאורי אור תחלתן
בסופן וסופן בתחלתן[iv] מארבע
כנפות הארץ והשמים יענו את
הארץ והמבין על מתכונתו
מה שאמרו בירושלמי מסכת
שבועות פרק ג׳ מלאכי חבלה

forming circuits for their deceased, this should not be called an optional matter but rather a religious duty for one who knows their significance in the mystery of the circuits.[1] Witness the conquest of Jericho and the circling of the altar during the offering of seventy bulls on the festival, with the various songs recited during the festival days, such as "Who will rise up for me against evildoers?" as stated in Tractate Sukkah, chapter "The Flute." And they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Sukkah, that nowadays the synagogue cantor stands like an angel of God with the Torah scroll in his arm, and the people circle around him like the altar.[2]

We have already stated in Discourse Three that in a place where there is no concern for quarreling,[A] it is good to accustom them to this practice. Then the soul of the departed will rejoice in the mystery of the dance and these circuits, and the lights will shine upon him, their beginning in their end and their end in their beginning,[3] from the four corners of the earth, and the heavens will answer the earth. One who understands its pattern, as they said in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shevuot, chapter three, "The angels of destruction have no ability to leap, as

[A] Or: "in a situation where there is no reason to worry about disputes arising" — This Aramaic phrase could be interpreted more broadly as referring to any situation (not just physical location) where conflict is unlikely. The alternate translation captures this broader possible meaning.

[1] The Hebrew word 'sod' (סוד) literally means 'secret' but in kabbalistic contexts refers to the mystical or esoteric dimension of a practice. The author is suggesting that circuits around the deceased have spiritual significance beyond their physical appearance.

[2] The comparison between synagogue practice (circling with the Torah) and Temple ritual (circling the altar) is significant, as it suggests that post-Temple Jewish practices were designed to spiritually parallel or substitute for Temple rituals.

[3] This phrase reflects a kabbalistic concept from Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) describing the circular nature of divine emanations. It suggests that the circuits create a complete spiritual circuit connecting the highest realms (beginning) with the lowest (end).

[i] This references the biblical account in Joshua 6 where the Israelites circled the walls of Jericho seven times before the walls fell. The author uses this as a precedent showing the spiritual power of ritual circuits.

[ii] This refers to the ritual of circling the altar during the festival of Sukkot, when a total of seventy bulls were sacrificed over the seven days of the festival. Each day, the priests would circle the altar while reciting different prayers.

[iii] This is a quote from Psalm 94:16, 'Who will rise up for me against the evildoers?' It appears to have been recited during the altar-circling rituals on Sukkot, according to the passage referenced in Tractate Sukkah.

[iv] This is a kabbalistic concept that appears in Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), describing the circular nature of divine energy where the highest point (beginning) connects with the lowest point (end). It reflects the idea that the circuits create a complete spiritual circle linking heaven and earth.

אין להם קפיצין[i] שנאמר משוט
בארץ והתהלך בה יבין טעם
ההקפות ולמה משהין פעמים
הרבה נושאי המטה כדי להפריח
רוחות[ii] גם ראיה במשנת מסכת
כלים כי העיירות המוקפות
חומה שבארץ ישראל שאין
קוברין שם מת לדברי הרמב״ם
בפרק ז׳ מהלכות בית הבחירה
עד שירצו ז׳ טובי העיר או כל
אנשי העיר ולדברי הראב״ד
בהשגה לעולם אין קוברין
ואפילו הכי מסבבים לתוכן מת
עד שירצו הנה שבסוד הסבוב
והמחול יעלזו חסידים בכבוד
וירננו על משכבותם[iii] וכל
שאין מתעסקין בתורה חייבין
להתעסק עם המת ואפילו איתיה כל צרכו[iv] לאותם דאין
מבטלין דברי תורה כך פסק
הרמב״ם פרק י״ד נגד דעת
השאלתות עיין שם בהגה״ה
וכתוב בירושלמי האנק מכאן
שצווחין על המתים כי הקול
עולה חלוק ומבסס הדין בסוד
תקיעת שופר וזה יהיה טעם למה
אמרינן במסכת שמחות כי בגוסס

it is said, ‘going to and fro in the earth, and walking up and down in it,’” will understand the reason for the circuits and why the bearers of the bier sometimes pause frequently in order to drive away spirits.[A] 35R

There is also evidence in the Mishnah of Tractate Kelim that in walled cities in the Land of Israel, where according to the Rambam in chapter seven of the Laws of the Temple, one may not bury the dead until seven city elders or all the townspeople consent—and according to the Raavad in his critique, one may never bury there—nevertheless, they would bring the deceased in circuits within them until they consented. This shows that through the mystery of circling and dancing, “the pious will rejoice in glory and sing upon their beds.” 40R 45R

And all those who are not engaged in Torah study[1] are obligated to attend to the deceased, even if all his needs are already provided for—this applies even to those for whom Torah study is not to be interrupted, as the Rambam ruled in chapter fourteen, against the opinion of the Sheiltot; see the note there. And it is written in the Jerusalem Talmud, “Groan,” from which we learn that we cry out for the dead, for the voice rises, divides, and establishes judgment in the mystery of the shofar blast.[2] This is the reason why we say in Tractate 50R 55R

[A] Or: “to disperse spiritual forces” — The Hebrew ‘ruchot’ can refer specifically to spirits/ghosts or more generally to spiritual forces/energies. This alternate translation avoids the potentially anachronistic connotation of ‘ghosts’ while preserving the mystical dimension.

[1] This statement addresses a tension in Jewish law between the obligation to study Torah (considered equivalent to all other commandments) and the obligation to attend to the dead. The author cites the Rambam’s position that even dedicated Torah scholars must participate in funeral proceedings.

[2] This cryptic phrase connects funeral lamentations with the shofar (ram’s horn) blast, suggesting that both serve to ‘divide’ or ‘separate’ negative judgments. In kabbalistic thought, the shofar’s sound breaks through negative decrees, and the author suggests funeral cries may function similarly.

[i] This Talmudic teaching states that ‘angels of destruction have no ability to leap,’ meaning they cannot travel instantaneously like certain divine messengers. The author cites this to explain why circuits are effective—they create a boundary that harmful spirits must travel around rather than cross directly.

[ii] Literally ‘to make spirits fly away,’ this phrase reveals the protective function of funeral pauses and circuits—they are understood to disperse harmful spiritual entities that might interfere with the deceased’s soul.

[iii] This is a quote from Psalm 149:5, ‘Let the pious exult in glory; let them sing for joy on their couches.’ The author applies this verse to the deceased, suggesting that proper funeral rites cause the souls of the righteous to rejoice even after death.

[iv] Even if all the deceased’s needs are already taken care of (such as having enough people for burial), implying that participation in funeral circuits has spiritual value beyond merely ensuring practical needs are met.

רבי יהודה אומר אם היה חכם משמיעין עליו מעשיו:[i][ii]

Semachot that concerning a dying person, Rabbi Yehudah says: If he was a sage, they proclaim his deeds.[1] 60R

פרק ל״א

Chapter 31

ממה דאמרינן בפרק אלו מגלחין על חכם חולץ מימין ועל אב בית דין דעדיפא מיניה כדפירש רש״י ע״כ חולץ משמאל[iii] מזה יצא המנהג לקרוע על שאר המתים הבגד העליון לבד מימין כמו שעל חכם חולץ מימין ועל אביו ואמו כל בגדיו משמאל וכן יתבאר מפשט דברי הגמרא שמנוהו בכלל החומרות שבאו

From what we learn in the chapter "Elu Megalchin" (Moed Katan),[2] regarding a sage, one removes the right shoe [in mourning], and for the head of the court, who is superior to him as Rashi explained, one removes the left shoe. From this arose the custom to tear for other deceased only the upper garment on the right side, just as for a sage one removes from the right, while for one's father and mother, one tears all garments from the left side. This is also explained from the plain meaning of the Talmud, which counts 5R 10R

[1] The practice of publicly recounting a scholar's accomplishments at their deathbed serves multiple purposes: honoring the deceased, providing a model for others to emulate, and possibly helping the soul's transition by emphasizing their merits before divine judgment.

[2] The Hebrew refers to a chapter in Tractate Moed Katan that deals with mourning practices. I've provided the transliteration and tractate name for clarity.

[i] This teaching from Tractate Semachot states that when a Torah scholar is dying, it is customary to publicly proclaim his good deeds and scholarly achievements. The author connects this to the 'voice' raised during funeral processions, suggesting a spiritual parallel.

[ii] Cf. Tractate Moed Katan — The passage opens by referencing a talmudic discussion where Rav Yosef criticized Rav Avia for performing mourning ceremonies that were not customary in that location, suggesting that local custom carries significant weight in mourning practices. | Cf. Book of Joshua — The reference to the conquest of Jericho draws a parallel between the biblical circling of Jericho's walls (which caused them to fall) and the ritual circling around the deceased, suggesting that these circuits have transformative spiritual power. | Cf. Tractate Sukkah — The text cites Tractate Sukkah regarding the practice of circling the altar during Sukkot with different songs each day, establishing a connection between Temple rituals and funeral practices. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse Three — The author self-references an earlier section of his own work where he apparently discussed similar concepts about funeral circuits, showing the interconnectedness of the book's parts. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shevuot — The citation about angels of destruction lacking the ability to leap is used to explain the spiritual mechanism behind funeral circuits—they create a boundary that harmful spirits cannot cross quickly. | Cf. Mishnah, Tractate Kelim — The reference to Tractate Kelim provides a halakhic basis for the practice of circuits, showing that even in places where burial was restricted, the procession of circuits was still permitted. | Cf. Psalms 149:5 — The phrase 'the pious will rejoice in glory and sing upon their beds' quotes Psalms 149:5, suggesting that the deceased righteous experience joy through the proper performance of these funeral circuits. | Cf. Maimonides (Rambam), Mishneh Torah — The citation of Maimonides establishes the halakhic framework regarding burial in walled cities, which is then used to demonstrate the importance of circuits even in places where burial itself might be restricted. | Cf. Raavad's critique on Maimonides — The mention of Raavad's stricter position highlights the author's awareness of halakhic debates while still arguing for the significance of circuits regardless of burial permissions. | Cf. Book of Ezekiel — The word 'ha'anek' (groan) appears to reference Ezekiel 24:17 where the prophet is commanded to 'sigh in silence' for the dead, which the Jerusalem Talmud interprets as evidence for vocal mourning. | Cf. Tractate Semachot — The reference to Tractate Semachot (a minor tractate on mourning) connects the circuits to the broader context of honoring the deceased, particularly emphasizing the special treatment for sages.

[iii] This refers to the ritual of removing shoes during mourning. For a sage (חכם), one removes the right shoe, while for the head of the court (אב בית דין), considered more important, one removes the left shoe. The author uses this as a basis for understanding clothing tear customs.

בהם הקריעה עד שיגלה את לבו מכלל שהיא מצד הלב ושם פירש רש״י בגמרא קריעה של שמאל הויא עדיפא בההוא יומי טפי מימין. ויזהר אדם בקריעה דחמירא מאבילות כדאמרינן בפרק אלו מגלחין אבלות לחוד וקריעה לחוד ולא אמרינן בה הלכה כדברי המיקל כדאמרינן באבילות. וכתוב בספר התרומה בהא דאמרינן הלכה כדברי המיקל באבל זהו בתנאי אבל לא באמוראי[i] והביאוהו הגהות מימוניות ריש פרק עשירי. עוד נתבאר בפרק ד׳ בשם סמ״ג דאבלות חמור טפי מאנינות. והקריעה מצד שמאל מלבד שמורה על קריעת הלב[ii] עוד לפי טבעו של אדם יד ימין בכחה נאדרי בקריעה לצד שמאל ממה שעושה יד שמאל ומורה שגם הימין נהפך לרועץ ובזה מודיע לכל צערו שיבקשו עליו רחמים ולכן קורע מבחוץ על אביו ועל אמו כדאמרי׳ בגמרא ומבדיל שפה כרבי יהודה דאפליג את״ק ואמר כל שאין מבדיל קמי שפה אינו אלא קרע של תיפלה[iii] ובשאר מתים פסקו כת״ק וטעם ההבדלה בקריעה זו יהיה כי בחינת השמאל שנפרד ונקרע היא מעירה חמתה הפך הימין שממתקת פיות הדין שדומיה שלה תהלה והקריעה היא בצואר והוא

this among the stringencies of tearing "until one reveals his heart," implying that it relates to the heart. There Rashi explained in the Gemara that tearing on the left side is superior on that day more than the right. 15R

One should be careful regarding tearing, which is more stringent than mourning, as we say in chapter "Elu Megalchin": "Mourning is one matter and tearing is another,"[1] and we do not apply the principle "the law follows the lenient opinion" to tearing as we do with mourning. It is written in Sefer HaTerumah that when we say "the law follows the lenient opinion in mourning," this applies only to Tannaim but not to Amoraim, as cited in Hagahot Maimoniot at the beginning of chapter ten. It is further explained in chapter four in the name of the Semag that mourning is more severe than aninut (acute mourning before burial). 20R 25R

Tearing on the left side, besides indicating the tearing of the heart, also relates to human nature: the right hand has greater strength in tearing toward the left than what the left hand can do, and it shows that even the right side (representing mercy) has been turned to severity. Through this, one makes known to all his grief so they will seek mercy for him. Therefore, one tears from the outside for one's father and mother, as stated in the Gemara, and separates the hem according to Rabbi Judah, who disagreed with the first Tanna and said that any tear that does not separate the hem is merely a tear of foolishness. For other deceased, the ruling follows the first Tanna. 30R 35R 40R

The reason for this separation in tearing is that the aspect of the left that is separated and torn arouses its anger, unlike the right which sweetens the mouths of judgment,[2] for its silence is praise. 45R

[1] This is a direct translation of the Talmudic statement "אבלות לחוד וקריעה לחוד" which establishes that the rules of tearing garments (keriah) are distinct from the general laws of mourning.

[2] The phrase "פיות הדין" (mouths of judgment) is a kabbalistic term referring to the outlets or expressions of divine judgment. I've maintained the imagery of "mouths" in the translation to preserve the original metaphor.

[i] The author cites Sefer HaTerumah's important distinction that the principle "the law follows the lenient opinion in mourning matters" applies only to Tannaitic sages (earlier authorities) but not to Amoraic ones (later authorities).

[ii] The author explains that tearing on the left side symbolizes the tearing of the heart, which is located on the left side of the body. This reflects the internal grief being externalized through the ritual action.

[iii] The author refers to a dispute between Rabbi Judah and the first Tanna (ת״ק) about whether the hem must be separated during tearing. Rabbi Judah requires separating the hem, calling a tear without this separation a "tear of foolishness."

מעומד כדמוכחינן בפרק אלו מגלחין במעשה דאמימר ואם קרע מיושב לא יצא וצריך לחזור ולקרוע לדברי הרי״ן גיאת והרמב״ם ומהרר״י קארו והרבה. וטעם לזה כי מורה שנעקר המת מעלמא דדכורא שרמז תחלתו ממקום הצוואר כי בחינת רישא הוא עלמא סתימא וירד לעלמא דנוקבא שסיבותיה אחרונות יורדות מות[i] ולכן קורע מעומד שדברים שהם נגד עלמא דדכורא הן לטוב הן למוטב לעולם הם בעמידה ואם היה קורע מיושב תהיה הוראה שירד גם מבחינת עלמא דנוקבא למקום החיצונים חס ושלום ולא ניחא למרי דאברהם דיימו הכי על בניה ולכן לא יצא. ויחזור ויקרע. והקריעה היא טפח שהוא כולל חמשה אצבעות מקומצים[ii] שיש חמשה מריבות בין בעלי הדין ונרמזו בברכת האל הרב את ריבנו שהם חמש, ושור וחמור צאן ועבד ושפחה הם חמשה מדרגות חצוניות שבהם מתלבשות חמשה היכלות שהם למטה מהיכל הרצון והיכל זה הוא בין מחנה שכינה הנקרא היכל קדש הקדשים למחנה

The tearing is at the neck area and must be done while standing, as we prove in chapter "Elu Megalchin" from the incident with Ameimar. If one tore while seated, it is invalid[A] and one must tear again,[1] according to Rabbi Isaac Giat, Maimonides, Rabbi Joseph Karo, and many others. 50R

The reason for this is that it signifies that the deceased has been uprooted from the masculine realm,[B] which begins at the neck, for the head aspect is the concealed realm,[2] and has descended to the feminine realm, whose final aspects descend to death. Therefore, one tears while standing, for matters relating to the masculine realm, whether for good or bad, are always done standing. If one were to tear while seated, it would indicate that the deceased had descended even lower, from the feminine realm to the realm of the external forces, God forbid, and it is not pleasing to the Master of Abraham that such would be thought about His children. Therefore, it is invalid and one must tear again. 55R 60R 65R

The tear must be a handbreadth,[3] which includes five clenched fingers, for there are five disputes between litigants, alluded to in the blessing "God who champions our cause," which are five. And ox, donkey, sheep, servant, and maidservant are five external levels in which are clothed five chambers that are below the Chamber of Will. This chamber is between the camp of the Divine Presence, called the Chamber of the Holy of Holies, and the camp of the 70R 75R

[A] Or: "he has not fulfilled his obligation" — The phrase "לא יצא" is a technical halakhic term indicating that one hasn't fulfilled a ritual obligation. While "it is invalid" conveys the general meaning, "he has not fulfilled his obligation" more precisely captures the legal terminology.

[B] Or: "world of the masculine principle" — "World of the masculine principle" is a more expanded translation that better conveys the cosmic and metaphysical dimensions of this kabbalistic concept, though "masculine realm" is more concise.

[1] The Hebrew "לא יצא" literally means "he has not fulfilled his obligation," a technical halakhic term indicating that the ritual action was invalid and must be repeated.

[2] I've translated the kabbalistic terms "עלמא דדכורא" as "masculine realm" and "עלמא סתימא" as "concealed realm." These reflect the author's use of kabbalistic concepts to explain ritual mourning practices.

[3] The Hebrew "טפח" refers to a specific halakhic measurement approximately equal to a handbreadth (about 3-4 inches or 8-10 cm). This is an important legal detail in the laws of tearing garments for mourning.

[i] This presents a kabbalistic interpretation of death as the soul's transition from the "masculine realm" (עלמא דדכורא) to the "feminine realm" (עלמא דנוקבא). The neck represents the boundary between the head (associated with the concealed realm) and the lower body (associated with the manifest realm).

[ii] The author specifies that the tear must be a handbreadth (טפח), which corresponds to five clenched fingers, and then provides kabbalistic symbolism for this number.

המלאכים ועליו אמר יעקב
והיה המחנה הנשאר לפליטה כי
כבודו לאחר לא יתן חס ושלום.
ובחוץ יש חמשה דמים טמאים
באשה ונודע כי למעלה במלכות
הגבורות הם חמשה בסוד שהיא
ה״א וכן יעקב קלל ה׳ מדרגות
קשות הדין ארור א׳ אפם ב׳ עז
ג׳ עברתם ד׳ קשתה ה׳ שאות ה׳
מתנהגת בקושי הדין והגבורות
החצונות. ביום הכפורים צריך
ה׳ ענויים למתק החמש גבורות
במקומן[i] ואכילה ושתיה היינו
ת״ת נקודה אמצעית ובזה הגוף
מתענה ומתחלש וסוד נשמה
למעלה מתגברת ועולה ורחמי
אריך מאירין:[ii]

angels. Concerning this Jacob said, "The remaining camp shall survive," for His glory He will not give to another, God forbid.

Externally, there are five impure bloods in a woman, and it is known that above in Malkhut, the powers of judgment are five, corresponding to the letter hei. Similarly, Jacob cursed five levels of harsh judgment: (1) "cursed be their anger," (2) "fierce," (3) "their wrath," (4) "cruel," (5) "I will divide them." The letter hei is conducted through the harshness of judgment and external severities. On Yom Kippur, five afflictions are required to sweeten the five powers of judgment[A] in their place, while eating and drinking correspond to Tiferet, the central point.[1] Through this, the body is afflicted and weakened, and the secret of the soul above is strengthened, rises, and the mercies of Arich Anpin shine forth.[B]

פרק ל״ב

Chapter 32

[A] Or: "to mitigate the five powers of severity" — "Mitigate the five powers of severity" might better convey the meaning to readers unfamiliar with the kabbalistic concept of "sweetening" (המתקה), which refers to the transformation of divine judgment into mercy.

[B] Or: "the compassions of the Long-Faced One illuminate" — This alternate translation provides the literal meaning of 'Arich Anpin' while maintaining the poetic quality of the original, though it might be less immediately clear to readers without kabbalistic background.

[1] Tiferet (ת״ת) is a central divine attribute in Kabbalah, often associated with harmony, beauty, and balance. It is frequently symbolized as the central point that mediates between mercy and judgment.

[i] The author connects the five afflictions of Yom Kippur to the five powers of judgment (גבורות), suggesting that the afflictions serve to "sweeten" or mitigate these judgments. This reflects the kabbalistic concept that physical practices have metaphysical effects.

[ii] Cf. Tractate Moed Katan 22b — The author uses this source as the foundation for the halakhic distinctions in mourning practices for different categories of deceased, particularly the symbolic significance of right versus left side in tearing. | Cf. Sefer HaTerumah (by Rabbi Baruch ben Isaac of Worms) — The author cites this work to establish that the principle of following the lenient opinion applies only to earlier Tannaitic authorities but not to later Amoraic authorities, reinforcing the stringency of tearing laws. | Cf. Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Laws of Mourning — The author references Maimonides among those who rule that tearing while seated is invalid, emphasizing the importance of proper ritual performance. | Cf. Genesis 32:9 — The author uses this verse in a kabbalistic context to describe the separation between spiritual realms, comparing Jacob's two camps to the division between the "Camp of the Divine Presence" and the "Camp of Angels." | Cf. Genesis 49:7 — The author interprets this verse as referring to five levels of harsh judgment, parsing out five specific terms from the curse to develop a kabbalistic structure of divine judgment. | Cf. Zohar — The author adapts Zoharic terminology to explain the metaphysical meaning of standing versus sitting during the tearing ritual. The position of the mourner corresponds to different cosmic realms through which the deceased's soul is transitioning. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 4 — The author refers back to this earlier section when mentioning that "it is further explained in chapter four in the name of the Semag that mourning is more severe than aninut," creating an internal cross-reference within the work.

בהקדמה שאמרנו תבין למה
קריעת אביו ואמו וחכם ונשיא
ואב בית דין ורוב הצבור וכו׳
כאשר פרטם הרמב״ם פרק ט׳
מהלכות אבל היא עד שיגלה
את לבו וכמה טעמים לפרטי
הקריעה וטעם הרבה דברים
אשר נאמרו באבל בגמרא
ובפוסקין ועל חמשה מאורעים
קורעין על מת ועל שמועות
רעות ועל ברכת ה׳ מישראל
ועל כתבי הקדש שנשרפו בזרוע
ועל ערי יהודה בחרבן וכל
שכן ירושלים ובית המקדש נגד
חמש סיבות הנזכרים וכן יש
בקדושה חמש תיבות בשם אלהים
וחמש אותיות מנצפ״ך שהם
פ״ר דינים[i] והאבל אסור בי״א
דברים כאשר הובאו בפרק אלו
מגלחין ובאבל רבתי ובהרמב״ם
פרק ה׳ מהלכות אבל נגד עשתי
עשרה יריעות שמחזין למחנה
מושבם[ii] והנה הרמב״ם בפרק
ט׳ פרט לי״א המקרים והדברים
שחייב לקרוע עליהם עד שיגלה
את לבו ואינם מאחים לעולם
ויעקב קרע שמלותיו על יוסף
להורות ששמלותיו העליונים לא
היו משתלמים על ידי אבודו של
יוסף[iii] וזה ג״כ טעם לקריעת

According to the introduction we presented, you will understand why the rending of garments for one's father, mother, a Torah scholar, a leader, the head of the court, the majority of the community, etc., as enumerated by Maimonides in chapter 9 of the Laws of Mourning,[1] must be done until one's heart is exposed. There are many reasons for the specific details of rending, and for many practices mentioned regarding mourning in the Talmud and legal authorities. We rend our garments for five types of occasions: for the dead, for bad tidings, for blasphemy against God by a Jew, for Torah scrolls burned with intent, and for the destruction of the cities of Judah—all the more so for Jerusalem and the Temple. These correspond to the five aforementioned causes.[2] Similarly, in the realm of holiness, there are five letters in the name Elohim and five final letters (MaNTZaPaKH), which represent 280 judgments.

The mourner is prohibited from eleven activities, as listed in the chapter "These are the ones who may cut their hair" in tractate Mo'ed Katan,[3] in Avel Rabbati,[4] and in Maimonides chapter 5 of the Laws of Mourning, corresponding to the eleven curtains that were outside the camp of their dwelling. Maimonides in chapter 9 details eleven cases and matters for which one must rend garments until one's heart is exposed, and these tears are never mended.

Jacob tore his garments over Joseph to indicate that his supernal "garments" could not be completed due to the loss of Joseph. This is also the reason for

[1] The text references Maimonides' (Rambam's) Mishneh Torah, his comprehensive legal code. The specific citation is to Hilkhot Avel (Laws of Mourning), chapter 9, which details the laws of rending garments (keriah).

[2] The author is establishing a mystical correspondence between the five occasions requiring rending garments and the five letters of God's name Elohim, suggesting that these rituals have cosmic significance beyond their practical observance.

[3] This refers to the third chapter of Talmudic tractate Mo'ed Katan, which begins with the words "Elu Megalchin" ("These are the ones who may cut their hair") and contains many laws of mourning.

[4] Avel Rabbati (Great Mourning) is another name for Masechet Semachot (Tractate of Joys), a minor tractate of the Talmud dealing with laws of mourning. The ironic title "Joys" is a euphemism for death and mourning customs.

[i] The Hebrew letters מנצפ״ך (MEM, NUN, TZADI, PEI, KAF in their final forms) have a gematria (numerical value) of 280, which is represented here by the Hebrew letters פ״ר (PEI-REISH). In Kabbalah, these letters represent the 280 forms of divine judgment.

[ii] This refers to the eleven goat-hair curtains that covered the Tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 26:7). The author is drawing a parallel between these eleven curtains, which were outside the sacred space, and the eleven mourning restrictions which mark a temporary separation from normal life.

[iii] This is a kabbalistic interpretation where "garments" (שמלות) refer to spiritual vestments or divine emanations. The author suggests that Jacob's tearing of his physical garments symbolized a disruption in the cosmic spiritual order due to Joseph's disappearance.

הבגדים על המת כל אחד סדינו
ולהיות שלא היה בוכה אלא על
התורה והמצוה אחר שהודיע
זה לבניו לכן ויבך אותו אביו
35 יותר משלשה לבכי.[i] ומצאתי
סמך לטעם זה של הקריעה
ממה דאמרינן בירושלמי כי רבי
יוחנן בעת פטירת רבי חנינא
אייתי מאני טבא דשבתא ובזע
40 עליה והובא בהגהות מהלכות
אבל עוד אמרו כי מהשפע
נעשת לבוש וזה סוד מלביש
ערומים כי מרוחא דנשיב מפומא
דאריך המתלבש זעיר וברוח
45 דזעיר מתלבש נוקביה[ii] וברוחא
דנוקביה מתלבשין כל חיילי
מלאכים דכתיב וברוח פיו כל
צבאם ועל זה נאמר ונתן לי בגד
ללבוש ושפע פנימי הוא סוד
50 המזון. ושתית העשרה כוסות
שהותר לשתות בבית האבל
ולא יותר כדאמרינן בכתובות
פרק קמא הוא למתק בהם י״א
קליפות ביין המשמח מצד י׳
55 נהורין[iii] שבהם יין המשמח ואין
להוסיף פן ישתכר ויצא לחוץ
ליינו של נח חם ושלום[iv] ואין
צריך לפרש יותר לחכם ועתה
בדורות אחרונים דלא אכשור
60 דרי בטלו אותם לגמרי כי
התחילו להיות שותין ומשתכרין

tearing garments over the deceased, each person tearing their own garment. And since Jacob wept only for the Torah and commandments after informing his sons of this, therefore "his father wept for him" more than the three days of weeping. 35R

I found support for this explanation of rending from what is stated in the Jerusalem Talmud that when Rabbi Yochanan, at the time of Rabbi Chanina's passing, brought his fine Sabbath garments and tore them, as cited in the glosses 40R to the Laws of Mourning.[1] It is further taught that from divine flow, garments are made, which is the secret of "clothing the naked."[2] For from the breath that flows from the mouth of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One), Zeir Anpin (the Small-Faced 45R One) is clothed, and from the breath of Zeir Anpin, its feminine counterpart is clothed, and from the breath of the feminine aspect, all the angelic hosts are clothed, as it is written: "By the breath of His mouth all their host."[3] Concerning this it is said: 50R "And He gave me a garment to wear." And the internal flow is the secret of nourishment.

The drinking of the ten cups that was permitted in the house of mourning, but no more, as stated in Ketubot chapter 1, is to sweeten the eleven husks 55R through the joy-inducing wine from the aspect of the ten lights within them—the wine that gladdens. One should not add more lest one become drunk and go outside to the wine of Noah, God forbid. There is no need to explain further to the wise. Now in recent 60R generations, when the generations have declined in

[1] This likely refers to the Hagahot Maimoniyot, a commentary on Maimonides' Mishneh Torah by Rabbi Meir HaKohen of Rothenburg (13th century).
[2] "Clothing the naked" (malbish arumim) appears in the daily morning prayers as one of God's attributes that humans should emulate. Here the author gives it a mystical interpretation, suggesting that divine emanation creates spiritual "clothing" throughout all levels of creation.
[3] This is a quotation from Psalm 33:6, which the author interprets kabbalistically to describe how divine breath/speech creates angelic beings.

[i] The phrase refers to Jacob mourning for Joseph beyond the customary three days of intense weeping, suggesting an extended period of grief.
[ii] This passage uses technical kabbalistic terminology describing how divine emanation flows downward: from the breath of Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One, representing a high divine configuration) comes the clothing of Zeir Anpin (the Small-Faced One, a lower divine configuration), and from Zeir's breath comes the clothing of its feminine counterpart (Nukvah/Malkhut).
[iii] According to Kabbalah, wine has the spiritual power to "sweeten" or mitigate harsh judgments. The ten cups correspond to the ten sefirot (divine emanations), while the eleven husks (kelipot) represent negative spiritual forces that require transformation.
[iv] This is an allusion to the biblical story of Noah becoming drunk and being uncovered in his tent (Genesis 9:21), which led to negative consequences. The author uses this as a cautionary example of excessive drinking.

כדאמרינן בפרק קמא דמגלה וכשתבין מה שכתבנו לעיל בפרק כ״ב בסוד התקונים והקשוטים והיחוד והזווג וסוד השערות וסוד הרחיצה וסיכה והשמלות תמצא טעם לאסור כל אחד מהם בימי האבל: [i]

quality,[1] they have completely abolished these cups because people began to drink and become intoxicated, as stated in the first chapter of Megillah. And when you understand what we wrote above in chapter 22 concerning the secret of the spiritual rectifications, adornments, unification, coupling, the secret of the hairs, and the secret of washing, anointing, and garments, you will find the reason for prohibiting each of these during the days of mourning.

פרק ל״ג

Chapter 33

סדר צדוק הדין הראוי לאבל לומר בפרט קודם שנקבר המת ואינו לפניו נתבאר בפרק מי שמתו שאומר צדיק אתה ה׳ על כל הבא עלינו יהי רצון מלפניך ה׳ אלהינו ואלהי אבותינו שתגדור פרצותינו ופרצות עמך ישראל ברחמים וגם מידי חזרתו לביתו מסכרא לאבולא יאמר כן ובפרק קמא דמס׳ ע״ג במעשה

The proper order of Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment)[2] for a mourner to recite, particularly before the deceased is buried and not in their presence, is explained in the chapter "One Whose Dead Relative" [in Tractate Berakhot]. The mourner says: "Righteous are You, O Lord, concerning all that has come upon us." [Then adds:] "May it be Your will, O Lord our God and God of our fathers, that You repair our breaches and the breaches of Your people Israel with mercy."[3] Likewise, upon

[1] The phrase "דלא אכשור דרי" ("the generations have declined in quality") is a common Talmudic expression indicating moral or spiritual deterioration over time. The author uses this to explain why certain mourning practices involving wine were discontinued.

[2] Tzidduk HaDin is a central Jewish mourning ritual in which mourners affirm the justice of God's decree even in the face of personal tragedy. This theological affirmation distinguishes Judaism's approach to grief, emphasizing acceptance of divine judgment while allowing for emotional expression.

[3] This prayer transitions from personal acceptance of judgment to communal concerns, reflecting Judaism's emphasis on seeing personal tragedy within the context of collective Jewish destiny and redemption.

[i] Cf. Exodus 26:7 — The author creates a mystical correspondence between the eleven curtains that were outside the sacred space of the Tabernacle and the eleven mourning restrictions that symbolize the mourner's temporary separation from normal life. This reflects the kabbalistic tendency to find cosmic significance in ritual practices. | Cf. Genesis 37:34 — The author interprets Jacob's tearing of garments kabbalistically, suggesting it symbolized a disruption in cosmic spiritual order. This exemplifies how Ma'avar Yabok consistently reads biblical narratives through a mystical lens, finding in them templates for mourning practices and their deeper significance. | Cf. Zohar — The kabbalistic terminology used here (Arich Anpin, Zeir Anpin, Nukvah) comes directly from the Zohar and later kabbalistic works. The author applies this cosmological framework to explain the spiritual significance of tearing garments during mourning, suggesting that physical actions create corresponding effects in higher spiritual realms. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Mo'ed Katan — The author cites this Talmudic story to demonstrate that even valuable garments should be torn to show proper respect for the deceased, especially for great scholars. This supports the author's broader argument about the importance of rending garments as a mourning practice with deep spiritual significance. | Cf. Genesis 9:20-23 — The author refers to "the wine of Noah" as a cautionary example against excessive drinking, even in the context of mourning rituals. This illustrates how Ma'avar Yabok integrates biblical narratives as moral guidance for appropriate ritual behavior. | Cf. Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Hilkhot Avel (Laws of Mourning) — The author uses Maimonides' legal code as an authoritative source for mourning practices, while simultaneously adding kabbalistic interpretations that go beyond the plain legal meaning. This demonstrates how Ma'avar Yabok integrates halakhic (legal) and mystical approaches to death rituals.

דרבי חנניא בן תרדיון מצינו כי סדר צדוק הדין הוא הצור תמים פעלו כי כל דרכיו משפט אל אמונה ואין עול צדיק וישר הוא. גדול העצה ורב העליליה אשר עיניך פקוחות על כל דרכי בני אדם. ושם אמר רבי כמה גדולים ג׳ צדוקים הללו שהיה הוא ואשתו ובתו שנזדמנו להם ג׳ מקראות של צדוק הדין בשעת צ״ה וגם שיש לומר כי אמרו ג׳ פסוקים אלו על מה שאירע להם כדאיתא שם ע״מ יצדקו ודאי בכל מין הצדקות דין וכן קבעום בראש סדר צדוק הדין והפסוק הא׳ יהיה להצדיק דין שמים מבעל המשפט שהוא מתווך שלום בין החסד והדין[i] והב׳ להמשיך חסד אל כי דין הגוף הוא חסד לנשמה[ii] באשר היה עסקנו בזה במאמר א׳ בפסוק גדול העצה והג׳ יהיה להמתיק הנהגת הדין מסוד והשפעת עינא פקיחא ועינין דמתלהטן יהו רוחצות בחלב האם.[iii] ובירושלמי סוף פרק ארבע מיתות אמרו רבנן לפני רבי אבהו שנפטר לו בן מה אם רשות שלמטן שיש בה שקר וכזב וגניבות דעת ומשוא פנים ומקח שחד והיום עודנו ומחר איננו נאמר בה הקרובים באים

returning home from closing the gate [after the funeral], one should say the same prayer.

In the first chapter of Tractate Avodah Zarah, in the account of Rabbi Hanina ben Teradion, we find that the order of Tzidduk HaDin is: "The Rock, His work is perfect, for all His ways are justice; a God of faithfulness without iniquity, righteous and upright is He" [Deuteronomy 32:4]. "Great in counsel and mighty in deed, whose eyes are open to all the ways of human beings" [Jeremiah 32:19]. And there Rabbi [Judah HaNasi] said: "How great are these three justifications," for Rabbi Hanina, his wife, and his daughter were granted three verses of Tzidduk HaDin at the time of distress. Although one could say they recited these three verses in response to what happened to them, as related there, they certainly justified judgment in all types of justification, and thus these verses were established at the beginning of the Tzidduk HaDin liturgy.

The first verse serves to justify heavenly judgment from the Master of Justice, who mediates peace between mercy and judgment.[1] The second verse draws forth divine kindness, for the judgment of the body is kindness to the soul,[2] as we discussed in the first discourse regarding the verse "Great in counsel." And the third verse sweetens the governance of judgment through the mystery of the influence of the watchful eye, and the flaming eyes are bathed in the milk of the Mother.[3]

In the Jerusalem Talmud, at the end of the chapter "Four Death Penalties," the Rabbis said to Rabbi

15R 20R 25R 30R 35R 40R

[1] The author provides a kabbalistic interpretation of each verse of Tzidduk HaDin, explaining how they function spiritually to balance cosmic forces of judgment and mercy. This represents a mystical dimension beyond the plain meaning of the prayers.

[2] This reflects the complex theological perspective that physical suffering or death, while painful in this world, can serve as spiritual purification or elevation for the soul—transforming apparent severity into ultimate kindness.

[3] This is deeply mystical language drawing from kabbalistic concepts. The 'flaming eyes' represent harsh divine judgment, while the 'milk of the Mother' refers to the nurturing, compassionate influence of the divine attribute of Binah (Understanding), often portrayed as a maternal force that softens judgment.

[i] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that judgment (din) and kindness (chesed) are divine attributes that need to be balanced and mediated. The 'Master of Justice' mediates between these attributes to ensure cosmic harmony.

[ii] This expresses a profound theological idea that physical suffering or death, while painful for the body, can be beneficial for the soul's spiritual journey—transforming apparent severity into kindness from a higher perspective.

[iii] This contains complex kabbalistic imagery: the 'watchful eye' (divine providence), 'flaming eyes' (divine judgment), and 'milk of the Mother' (soothing influence from Binah/Understanding). The metaphor suggests harsh judgment being softened by maternal divine nurturing.

ושואלים שלום הדיינים והעדים
לומר שאין בלבנו עליכם כלום
שדין אמת דנתם, רשות של מעלן
שאין בה לא כזב ולא שקר ולא
גניבת דעת ולא משוא פנים
ולא מקח שחד והוא חי וקיים
לעולמי עולמים על אחת כמה
וכמה שחייבים אנו לקבל עלינו
מדת הדין. ויזהר האבל שלא
יפתח פיו לשטן[i] כי החרב היינו
כח הדין מונחת לו בין כתפיו
ומשלשה ועד שבעה כאילו
מונחת כנגדו בקרן זוית[ii] וכו׳
כדאמרי׳ במועד קטן וצריך
האבל לפחד ולדאג ולפשפש
במעשיו ויחזור בתשובה וכן
הוא אומר הכיתי אותם ולא חלו
מכלל דצריך להקיץ ולחול וכן
המנחמים יזהרו בדבריהם עמו
שלא יתנו מקום למקטרג לתפוש
דבריהם וכ״ש מבקרי החולה
כדאמר רבי יוחנן התם לכל
אומרין שבו חוץ מאבל וחולה
דמשמע שב באבילות שלך שב
בחולי שלך[iii] וה״ה לכל דבר
הדומה לזה שלא ימצא מקום
בעל דין לחלוק ולעורר מדנים
נגד מי דכבר איתרע מזליה
ומעשים הרבה באו במס׳ מועד
קטן דפעמים דברים ממיתים
כדאמרי׳ אילו בדידך הוה וכו׳.
והיה כשגגה שיוצאת מלפני
השליט וכן הרבה בגמרא כי
העולם הזה לא נברא אלא לבחון
בו הבריות ופעמים אדם מת
על ידי מקרה אבל לעתיד לבא
כתיב כי הנער בן מאה שנה ימות

Abbahu, who had lost a son: "If in an earthly court, which contains falsehood, deception, theft of knowledge, favoritism, and bribery, and which exists today but may not tomorrow, it is said that the relatives come and ask after the welfare of the judges and witnesses, declaring, 'We bear no ill will against you, for you have judged a true judgment'—then regarding the heavenly court, which contains no deception, no falsehood, no theft of knowledge, no favoritism, no bribery, and which exists and endures forever and ever, how much more are we obligated to accept the attribute of judgment upon ourselves."

The mourner should be careful not to "open his mouth to Satan,"[1] for the sword—that is, the power of judgment—rests between his shoulders from the third to the seventh day [of mourning], as if placed opposite him in a corner, etc., as stated in Tractate Mo'ed Katan. The mourner needs to fear, worry, examine his deeds, and return in repentance. As it says [in Jeremiah 5:3]: "I have struck them, but they did not feel it," implying that one must awaken and feel [the divine rebuke]. Similarly, those who comfort the mourner should be careful with their words, not giving the accuser an opportunity to seize upon their words. This applies all the more so to those visiting the sick, as Rabbi Yohanan said there: "To all we say 'sit,' except to a mourner and a sick person," as this would imply "remain in your mourning" or "remain in your sickness." The same applies to anything similar that might give the prosecutor grounds to contend and stir up strife against one whose fortune has already been compromised.

Many incidents are recorded in Tractate Mo'ed Katan where words can cause death, as we say, "If it were to happen to you..." It is like an error that proceeds from the ruler. There are many such examples in the Talmud, for this world was created only to test

[1] This reflects the Jewish belief that one's words can create spiritual realities, and negative statements might invite misfortune. Mourners are especially vulnerable to accidental negative self-fulfilling prophecies through careless speech.

[i] This reflects the Jewish belief that one should avoid negative speech that might invite misfortune, based on the idea that words have power to create reality and that Satan (the accuser) might use one's own words against them.

[ii] This metaphorical image describes how the power of judgment remains especially potent during different phases of the mourning period, with specific temporal markers (from day three to day seven) having different spiritual significances.

[iii] This demonstrates the Jewish attention to nuanced language, where even a seemingly innocuous word like 'sit' (שב) could be interpreted as a command to 'remain' in a negative state, showing how carefully language should be used around those who are vulnerable.

ולא ימצא צדוק ורע לו רשע
80 וטוב לו דכתיב ושבתם וראיתם
בין צדיק לרשע וגו׳ ואם הנפטר
הוא אחד מבניו בפרט ומת שלא
כדרכו של עולם ח״ו כל שכן
שצריך פשפוש ומשמוש במעשיו
85 כי הלא דבר הוא כדחזינן
במס׳ תענית פ׳ מאימתי במעשה
דחולדה ובור[i] המובא בפירוש
רש״י ובתוס׳ ובספר הערוך ג״כ
שאמרה אשתו לבעלה במיתת
90 בניה אילו בדרך בני אדם היו
מתים הייתי אומרת צד״ה עבשו
שמתו מיתה משונה עון הוא
וכו׳. ובמרירות רוחו ילחוש
לה׳ ויענה ואם לחש ולא נענה
95 אמרו בתענית מאי תקנתיה
ילך אצל חסיד שבדור וירבה
עליו בתפלה[ii] שנאמר ויצו
עליו במפגיע ואין פגיעה אלא
תפלה מכאן גם כן סמך לתפלה
100 שמתפלל החכם על החולה וכן
כתיב יגיד עליו רעו והוא רחום
יכפר. והוכיח הרמב״ן פרשת
יתרו כי תפלה על החולים יקרא
דרישת אלהים וכן ודרשת את ה׳
105 לאמר האחיה מחולי זה פירוש
שיתפלל עליו וכן ותלך לדרוש
את ה׳.[iii]

creatures,[1] and sometimes a person dies by chance. But in the future, it is written [Isaiah 65:20]: "For the youth shall die a hundred years old," and there will no longer be a righteous person who suffers or a wicked person who prospers, as it is written [Malachi 3:18]: "Then you shall again discern between the righteous and the wicked." 80R 85R

If the deceased is one of his children in particular, and the child died unnaturally, God forbid, all the more so does one need to search and examine one's deeds, for surely it is significant, as we see in Tractate Ta'anit, chapter "From When," in the story of the weasel and the pit, as brought in Rashi's commentary, in Tosafot, and also in the Arukh. There, a man's wife said to him upon the death of their children: "If they had died in the manner of all people, I would say it is the decree of divine judgment. Now that they have died an unusual death, it is a sin," etc. 90R 95R

In the bitterness of his spirit, he should whisper to the Lord, who will answer him. If he whispered but was not answered, they said in Tractate Ta'anit: "What is his remedy? Let him go to the pious person of the generation, who should increase prayer on his behalf, as it is said [Job 36:32]: 'He commands concerning him with a plea,' and 'plea' refers only to prayer." From here we also have support for the prayer that a sage offers for the sick. And so it is written [Job 36:33]: "His friend declares concerning him, and He, being merciful, atones." 100R 105R

[1] This theological statement frames suffering as purposeful within a divine plan of spiritual testing and growth, rather than random misfortune. It provides a framework for understanding tragedy as meaningful even when painful.

[i] This refers to a Talmudic story (Ta'anit 8a) about children who died unusually when a weasel emerged from a hole and bit them. Their father was initially comforted by attributing their deaths to their predestined time, but his wife argued that the unusual circumstances indicated divine displeasure requiring repentance.

[ii] This establishes the Jewish practice of seeking intercession from exceptionally pious individuals when one's own prayers seem ineffective, reflecting the belief that some individuals have special spiritual access or merit with God.

[iii] Cf. Tractate Berakhot 59b — The passage from Berakhot establishes the basic prayer formula for accepting divine judgment, which became central to the Tzidduk HaDin ritual. | Cf. Deuteronomy 32:4 — This central verse affirms divine justice even in the face of tragedy, forming the theological core of accepting God's judgment. | Cf. Jeremiah 32:19 — This verse emphasizes God's providential awareness of all human actions, suggesting that divine judgment is based on complete knowledge rather than arbitrary decisions. | Cf. Avodah Zarah 18a — This reference connects the Tzidduk HaDin liturgy to a powerful narrative of martyrdom, suggesting that these verses were meaningful even in the most extreme circumstances of suffering. | Cf. Mo'ed Katan 27b — This metaphorical image of judgment hovering over the mourner explains why extreme caution is needed in speech during the mourning period. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Sanhedrin 6:6 — This powerful a fortiori argument suggests that if one accepts human judgment despite its flaws, one should certainly accept

Nahmanides, in his commentary on Parshat Yitro, proved that prayer for the sick is called "seeking God,"[1] as in [2 Kings 8:8]: "And you shall inquire of the Lord, saying, 'Shall I recover from this illness?'" meaning that one should pray for him. Similarly [2 Kings 22:18]: "And she went to inquire of the Lord." 110R 115R

פרק ל״ד

Chapter 34

מצאתי קצת סמך למה שאמר רבי יהושע בגמרא כי אין התחלת האבלות רק כשיסתום הגולל שכן דוד רחץ וסך כשמת הילד קודם שיקבר וכבר דרשו מחצדי חקלא בבחינת נפש הילד הזה בפירוש בר נפלי[i] וסמך הנזכר הוא במה שאמרו במדרש תהלים על האבות שלא נקראו קדושים עד שניתנו בארץ ונסתם הגולל בפניהם וכן כתוב במדרש תנחומא פ׳ תולדות על פסוק לקדושים אשר בארץ המה אימתי הם קדושים כשהם נתונים בארץ ואולי יהיה בסוד חזרת הדברים אל נרתקן כי אז הוא שלמותן ותמימותן בסוד כי עפר אתה ואל עפר תשוב[ii] שדברנו ממנו בפ׳ כ״ז ממאמר ב׳ ואמרו במדרש קהלת אימתי והרוח

I found some support for Rabbi Joshua's statement in the Talmud that mourning only begins when the grave is sealed,[A] as we see that David washed and anointed himself when the child died before it was buried. The Kabbalistic scholars ("reapers of the field"[2]) have already expounded on the soul of this child in the explanation of "son of the fallen." The aforementioned support is found in the Midrash Tehillim regarding the Patriarchs, who were not called "holy ones" until they were placed in the earth and the grave was sealed before them. Similarly, it is written in Midrash Tanchuma, Parashat Toldot, on the verse "To the holy ones who are in the earth"—when are they holy? When they are placed in the earth. 5R 10R 15R

Perhaps this relates to the mystical concept of things returning to their sheath, for that is their perfection and completeness, as in the secret meaning of "for dust you are, and to dust you shall return," which we discussed in chapter 27 of Discourse 2. The 20R

[A] Or: "that the mourning period only commences when the grave is sealed" — This alternate translation might be preferable in formal contexts as it more precisely conveys the legal (halakhic) nature of the beginning of the mourning period.

[1] Nahmanides (Ramban, 1194-1270) was a major Spanish Talmudist, kabbalist, and biblical commentator whose interpretations are highly respected in Jewish tradition. His linking of healing prayer with 'seeking God' elevates medical concerns to a spiritual plane.

[2] The term 'מחצדי חקלא' (reapers of the field) is a technical term from the Zohar referring to kabbalistic sages who 'harvest' mystical wisdom. I've chosen to translate it literally but clarify with 'Kabbalistic scholars' to convey the proper meaning.

divine judgment which is perfect. | Cf. Ta'anit 8a — This reference suggests that unnatural deaths particularly call for introspection, as they may indicate divine displeasure rather than natural causes.

[i] The term 'bar nefli' (son of the fallen) is likely a reference to the Talmudic identification of the Messiah in Sanhedrin 96b-97a, where this phrase is applied to the Messiah using a play on words from Amos 9:11 regarding the 'fallen booth of David.' Here it may suggest a mystical interpretation of the deceased child's soul.

[ii] This biblical quotation (Genesis 3:19) is being interpreted not merely as a statement about physical decomposition but as revealing a mystical principle about the completion of the soul's journey and its preparation for resurrection.

תשוב אל האלהים אשר נתנה
כשישוב העפר אל הארץ כשהיה
ואם לאו נפש אויבך יקלענה
על כן אמרינן בגמרא האומר
אל תקברוהו אין שומעין לו
ומצינו שהאבות היו מחבבין
הקבורה כדאמרי׳ במדרש רבה
ובתנחומא ואמרו שם אבילו
אדם מת בספינה הנפש הולכת
אצל אבותיו וכן אמר יעקב
כשאני מסתלק אצל אבותי אני
הולך, והנותן מתו בארון ולא
קברו בקרקע עובר משום מלין
את המת וכבר אמרו הפוסקים
כי יפה לקוברו בקרקע ממש
ואפילו בחוצה לארץ ורבי
חזקיה מוסיף בצוואת של רבי
תהא ארוני זקופה לארץ וגם
שאמרו שם מפני העכול מכל
מקום יהיה משם ראיה שכל עוד
שגוף האדם סמוך לקרקע טוב
לו. ומצאתי כי סוד הקבורה
היא כניסת הנשמה לגן עדן ולזה
לא נקנה לאברהם איש החסד
המערה עד מיתת שרה וקנייתה
היתה בארבע מאות שקל כסף
דאינון עלמין דכסופא ושעשוע
הצדיקים[i] ואברהם בחר לו
קבורתו שם עם אדם וחוה לפי
שנפשותיהם של רשעים שהם
המזיקים ורצה להתרחק מהם
ושם במערה היו ד׳ פנים וד׳
כנפים הויה בזכרים ואדנות

Midrash Kohelet states: When does "the spirit return to God who gave it"? When "the dust returns to the earth as it was." If not, "He will sling out the souls of your enemies." Therefore, we say in the Talmud that if someone says, "Do not bury him," we do not listen to him.[A] 25R

We find that the Patriarchs cherished burial, as stated in Midrash Rabbah and Tanchuma. They said there that even if a person dies on a ship, the soul goes to its ancestors. Thus Jacob said, "When I depart to my fathers, I will go." One who places his dead in a coffin without burying it in the ground transgresses the prohibition against leaving the dead unburied. The legal authorities have already stated that it is best to bury directly in the ground, even outside the Land of Israel. Rabbi Hezekiah adds in Rabbi's testament: "Let my coffin be upright to the ground." Although they said this was for the sake of decomposition, this nonetheless proves that as long as a person's body is close to the ground, it is good for him. 30R 35R 40R

I found that the secret of burial is the soul's entrance into the Garden of Eden. For this reason, the cave was not acquired for Abraham, the man of kindness, until Sarah's death. Its purchase was for four hundred silver shekels, corresponding to the worlds of divine delight and the righteous ones' pleasure.[B] Abraham chose his burial place there with Adam and Eve because the souls of the wicked become harmful spirits,[1] and he wanted to distance himself from them. In that cave were four faces and four wings—YHVH for the males and ADNY for the females.[2] 45R 50R

[A] Or: "if one requests not to be buried, this request is disregarded" — This alternative more clearly conveys that this refers to someone requesting not to be buried themselves (rather than requesting someone else not be buried).

[B] Or: "which represent the realms of spiritual longing and the delight of the righteous" — This alternate captures another nuance of 'כסופא' which can mean both 'delight' and 'longing/yearning' in kabbalistic terminology.

[1] The original Hebrew uses a word that literally means 'damagers' or 'harmful ones' (המזיקים), which in Jewish mystical tradition refers to destructive spiritual entities often associated with the souls of the wicked.

[2] This is a kabbalistic concept referring to the divine names as they manifest in the spiritual structure of the burial cave. The four faces likely refer to the four letters of the divine name, while the wings represent the extension of divine influence.

[i] The author gives a kabbalistic interpretation to Abraham's purchase of the Cave of Machpelah, suggesting that the 400 silver shekels correspond to spiritual realms of divine delight where righteous souls experience pleasure in the afterlife.

בנקבות.[i] ונייחא למת שיקנו
55 לו קרקע אחוזתו באשר נראה
בהרבה מקומות מדברי רבותינו
ולכן מפנין אותו אפילו מקבר
מכובד לבזוי אם היה בתוך
שדהו כדאמרינן בירושלמי
60 ופסקו הרמב"ם בפרק י"ד.
וכתוב במסכת שמחות ובס'
התרומה כי האבל אומר לרבים
הבאים לנחמו משום כבודם
לכו לבתיכם לשלום ושכרכם
65 כפול מן השמים וזה אינו בכלל
שאלת שלום דאסור בשלשה ימים
הראשונים[ii]

It is restful for the dead when they are purchased land for their possession, as is evident in many places 55R
in our rabbis' teachings. Therefore, we move the deceased even from an honorable grave to a dishonorable one if it was within his own field, as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud and ruled by Maimonides in chapter 14. It is written in Tractate Semachot and 60R
in Sefer HaTerumah that the mourner says to the many who come to comfort him, out of respect for them: "Go to your homes in peace, and may your reward be doubled from Heaven." This is not included in the prohibition against greeting during the first 65R
three days of mourning.

פרק ל"ה

Chapter 35

כתוב בספר תורת האדם
כי קבלה מיד אחד מרבותיו
שרחיצת ידים בבואם מבית
הקברות ותלישת עשבים רמז
5 לטהרת הטומאה לומר טומאה
זו אינה ניתרת אלא בעין שלשה

It is written in the book Torat Ha'Adam that one of his teachers handed down a tradition[A] that washing the hands upon returning from the cemetery[1] and plucking grass[2] symbolizes purification from impurity,[B] suggesting that this impurity can only 5R
be cleansed through three elements: water, ash,

[A] Or: "he received a tradition directly from one of his teachers" — This more literal translation emphasizes the direct transmission of the tradition from teacher to student, which is significant in rabbinic culture.

[B] Or: "alludes to the purification from ritual impurity" — This alternate specifies that the impurity being discussed is ritual impurity (tumah), a specific halakhic category rather than general uncleanliness.

[1] This refers to the Jewish practice of netilat yadayim (ritual hand washing) after visiting a cemetery, which is still observed today. The custom is meant to remove ritual impurity (tumah) believed to be contracted in the presence of the dead.

[2] This refers to the practice of plucking grass at a cemetery and throwing it behind one's back. Various explanations exist for this custom beyond the resurrection symbolism mentioned here, including representing the cycle of life and death or acknowledging that humans, like grass, will eventually wither.

[i] This is a kabbalistic description of the Cave of Machpelah as containing mystical configurations of the divine names: YHVH (associated with the masculine divine attribute) and ADNY (associated with the feminine divine attribute).

[ii] Cf. Midrash Tehillim — The text cites Midrash Tehillim to support the idea that the Patriarchs were not called 'holy ones' until after their burial, suggesting burial completes a spiritual transition. | Cf. Midrash Tanchuma — The citation from Midrash Tanchuma reinforces the notion that holiness is attained through burial, interpreting the verse 'To the holy ones who are in the earth' to mean that sanctity is achieved when one is placed in the earth. | Cf. Genesis 3:19 — The biblical verse is referenced to support the mystical concept that returning to earth through burial represents a completion of the soul's earthly journey. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 12:7 — This verse is cited to show that the soul's return to God is contingent upon the body's return to earth through burial. | Cf. Zohar — The reference to 'מחצדי חקלא' (reapers of the field) is a term commonly used in the Zohar for kabbalistic sages, suggesting that mystical interpretations of the child's soul had been developed in kabbalistic literature.

דברים הללו במים ואפר ואזוב ואמר כי זה טעם יפה ורבינו ישעיה כתב בהגהה כי המים והעפר אלו הם רמז ליצירה ולמיתה וסמך דבריו במדרש שאמרו במדרש רבה[i] על למה מים ועפר שתחלתה מן המים וסופו לעפר לפיכך נבדקת במים ובעפר אם טהורה היא כברייתא ואם לאו חזרת לעפרה כן הרמז כאן ליצירה ולמיתה כנזכר והעשב רמז לתחית המתים כמו שנאמר ויציצו מעיר[ii] וגו׳ ואת אשר הורינו ה׳ בטעם מנהגים אלו העלינו בפני המעיין במאמר ב׳[iii] [iv]

and hyssop.[1] He stated that this is a beautiful explanation. Rabbi Isaiah wrote in a gloss that the water and earth symbolize creation and death, supporting his words with a midrash that appears in Midrash Rabbah explaining why water and earth are used: "Because man's beginning is from water and his end is dust; therefore, the woman suspected of adultery is examined with water and dust[2]—if she is pure as when first created,[A] [she is vindicated], and if not, she returns to her dust." Thus, the symbolism here refers to creation and death as mentioned. The grass symbolizes the resurrection of the dead, as it is written, "They shall flourish from the city, etc." As for what the Lord has taught us regarding the reasons for these customs, we have presented them to the reader in Discourse 2.

10R 15R 20R

פ׳ ל׳ ול״א וגם במאמר ג׳ פ״כ. בסוף גמרא במסכת שמחות כתוב הנפטר מן המת יאמר לו לך בשלום שנאמר ואתה תבא אל אבותיך בשלום וכתב הר״ן כי מפני שהוא נבעת צריך לפוקדו לשלום בהליכתו וכזה פסק

At the end of chapters 30 and 31, and also in chapter 20 of the third discourse, it is written in the concluding section of Tractate Semachot that one who takes leave of the dead should say to them, "Go in peace," as it is said, "And you shall go to your fathers in peace" (Genesis 15:15). The Ran explains that because the deceased is frightened, it is necessary to bid

25R

[A] Or: "if she is pure as in her original state of creation" — This alternate more clearly conveys the meaning of 'כברייתא' as referring to the woman's original created state, making the theological parallel more explicit.

[1] These three elements were used in the biblical purification ritual for someone who had come into contact with a corpse, as described in Numbers 19. The ritual involved sprinkling water mixed with the ashes of a red heifer using a hyssop branch.

[2] This refers to the sotah ritual described in Numbers 5:11-31, where a woman suspected of adultery would drink water mixed with dust from the Tabernacle floor. The outcome of this ritual was believed to reveal her guilt or innocence.

[i] The text refers to a teaching from Midrash Rabbah, a collection of homiletical interpretations of the Torah. The specific midrash cited appears to relate to the ritual of the sotah (a woman suspected of adultery), comparing her examination with water and dust to human creation and mortality.

[ii] This is a quote from Psalm 72:16, which reads in full: "May grain abound throughout the land; on the tops of the hills may it sway. May the crops flourish like Lebanon and thrive like the grass of the field." The author uses this verse to connect the sprouting of grass with the concept of resurrection.

[iii] The author refers to having already discussed these customs in Discourse 2 of Ma'avar Yabok, showing the interconnected nature of the work and suggesting that this passage is part of a later discourse.

[iv] Cf. Sotah ritual — The author uses the sotah ritual as a parallel to explain the symbolism of water and earth in cemetery rituals, suggesting both involve transformation or revelation of one's true nature. | Cf. "They shall flourish from the city" — The author cites this verse as biblical support for grass symbolizing resurrection, drawing a parallel between plants sprouting from the earth and the dead rising from their graves. | Cf. Water, ash, and hyssop — The author connects cemetery practices to the biblical purification ritual that specifically addresses corpse impurity, suggesting these modern customs preserve the symbolic elements of the ancient ritual.

הרמב״ם בפרק ד׳ מהלכות אבל
שחובה למלוין לומר כן והיאך
יתנהגו המנחמים בא מפורש שם
בגמרא ולהיות כי המנחם מעורר
כח הימין לכן האבלים עומדים
לשמאלו כדאמרינן באבל רבתי
ובתשובת הגאונים וכן פסק
הרמב״ם בפרמ י״ג מהלכות אבל
ואומרים להם תנוחמו מן השמים
שהיא בשום הדין ברחמים ומטה
הכרעתו כלפי חסד. ובכל יום
באים בני אדם לנחמו שבכל יום
צריך מיתוק חדש ופנים חדשות
עדיפי כי כל ז׳ גבורות חיצונות
הזרות מתדבקות[i] שכיון שפותחת
אחד מהם בדין כלם גוברות
כמו שבנדה ישראלית אפילו
תראה רק יום א׳ בכל שבעה
ימים יש שליטת הנחש[ii] ולכן
משכבה ומושבה ומרכבה טמא
בימי חסרונה שהמשכב וחבריו
הם רמז למדרגות החצונות

them farewell with words of peace as they depart. Similarly, Maimonides ruled[A] in chapter 4 of the Laws of Mourning that it is obligatory for those accompanying the deceased to say this.[1] How mourners should conduct themselves is explicitly stated there in the Talmud.

Since the comforter awakens the power of the right side (mercy), the mourners stand to his left,[2] as stated in Avel Rabbati and in the responsa of the Geonim, and as Maimonides ruled in chapter 13 of the Laws of Mourning. The comforters say to them, "May you be comforted from Heaven," which places divine judgment within mercy and tips the balance toward lovingkindness.[3]

People come each day to comfort the mourner because each day requires new sweetening of judgment,[B] and new faces are preferable, for all seven external, foreign powers of severity[C] cling to the mourner.[4] Once one of these powers opens with judgment, they all gain strength. This is similar to a menstruating Israelite woman who, even if she sees blood on only one day, the influence of the serpent

[A] Or: "And Maimonides issued this ruling" — While 'similarly' captures the comparison being made, the alternate is more direct about indicating that Maimonides specifically codified this exact ruling mentioned previously.

[B] Or: "each day requires fresh spiritual amelioration" — The term 'mituk' (sweetening) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the transformation of divine judgment into mercy. While 'sweetening of judgment' is accurate, 'spiritual amelioration' might be more accessible for readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[C] Or: "seven external powers of severity that are alien in nature" — This alternate translation emphasizes that these 'gevurot' (powers of severity/judgment) are not only external but fundamentally foreign or alien to the natural spiritual order, which more fully captures the nuance of 'zarot' (strange/foreign).

[1] The original text uses 'melavin' (מלוין), which refers specifically to those who accompany the deceased to burial, not just any attendees at a funeral.

[2] This physical positioning has mystical significance in Kabbalah, where the right side represents mercy (Chesed) and the left side represents judgment (Gevurah). By standing to the comforter's left, the mourner positions himself to receive the flow of mercy from the comforter's right side.

[3] The Hebrew phrase 'mateh hachraato klapei chesed' alludes to the rabbinic concept that God judges 'tipping the scales toward mercy,' a principle found in the Talmud (Rosh Hashanah 17a).

[4] This is a kabbalistic explanation for the seven-day mourning period (shiva), suggesting that each day corresponds to a different aspect of divine judgment that must be 'sweetened' or transformed into mercy through the comfort offered by visitors.

[i] This refers to the kabbalistic concept of seven external powers of judgment (representing the seven lower sefirot in their aspect of severity) that affect the mourner during the seven days of mourning. These powers are considered 'foreign' or 'alien' (zarot) because they represent an intrusion of harsh judgment into normal life.

[ii] The author draws a parallel between menstrual impurity and mourning, noting that just as a menstruant remains ritually impure for seven days even if she bleeds only on one day, so too the mourner is affected by the 'serpent' (representing negative spiritual forces) for all seven days of mourning.

שהם דין בני חלוף מרכבה
טמאה[i] ולכן שוין בזה הזב והזבה
והנדה והיולדת. ועדיף טומאת
התחתון מכלים הראויים למדרס
מטומאות העליון שאינו אלא
מדף והתחתון אב לטומאה.
וזה טעם לכל הדינים ולבשעת
ימי טומאה והפרשה בכל מקום
עוד יש להם דוקא טומאת הסט
בטהור. וכן מצינו כי שבעה
מיני כלים מקבלים טומאה
מן התורה[ii] כדאמרו בתורת
כהנים ובהרמב״ם ריש פרק
א׳ דכלים וסמ״ג עשין רמ״ו
וכשתדקדק במיני החצונים
הנקובים בפסוקים לא יעלו יותר
על שבעה מינים ודי למבין. ולכן
האבל אינו משלח קרבנותיו
כל שבעה אפילו יין או עצים
או לבונה כדאמרי׳ בפרק אלו
מגלחין וכן פסק הרמב״ם פ״ב
מהלכות ביאת מקדש וסמ״ג
לאוין י״ג ופשוט כי נחום
האבלים מלבד כי הוא יקרא
דחיי גם הוא נייחא דשכבי ולכן
תנחומי האבל קודם לשמחת חתן
כדפסק מהר״י קארו בסי׳ ש״ס.
[iii]

remains for all seven days. Therefore, her bed, seat, and conveyance become impure during her days of impurity, for the bed and its companions symbolize the external levels that are judgments subject to exchange—an impure vehicle. For this reason, the man with discharge, the woman with discharge, the menstruant, and the woman after childbirth are all equal in this regard. 55R

The impurity of the lower entity from vessels suitable for treading is more severe than the impurity of the upper entity, which is merely considered "a shaking" (midaf), while the lower is a primary source of impurity (av ha-tumah). This is the reason for all the laws concerning the time of impurity and separation in every place. Additionally, they specifically have the impurity of displacement when touching something pure. 60R 65R

We also find that seven types of vessels receive impurity according to the Torah,[1] as stated in Torat Kohanim and by Maimonides at the beginning of chapter 1 of the Laws of Vessels, and in Sefer Mitzvot Gadol, positive commandment 246. When you examine carefully the types of external forces (chitzonim) mentioned in the verses, they do not exceed seven types, and this is sufficient for the wise to understand. 70R 75R

Therefore, a mourner does not send his offerings during all seven days, not even wine, wood, or

[1] The author is drawing a mystical parallel between the seven types of vessels that can become ritually impure according to Torah law and the seven types of external negative forces that affect mourners, suggesting that the laws of ritual impurity have deeper spiritual significance.

[i] The author is employing kabbalistic symbolism, interpreting the laws of ritual impurity as reflecting spiritual realities. The bed, seat, and conveyance of a menstruant symbolize external levels of reality dominated by judgment (din) rather than mercy, and subject to exchange or fluctuation (bnei chiluf), serving as a vehicle (merkavah) for impurity.

[ii] The Torah specifies seven categories of vessels that can become ritually impure: those made of metal, wood, animal hide, cloth, sackcloth, earthenware, and glass. The author suggests that these correspond to seven types of external negative forces mentioned in Scripture.

[iii] Cf. Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Laws of Mourning, chapter 4 — The author cites Maimonides to establish the halakhic requirement for those attending a funeral to say specific words when departing from the deceased, grounding this ritual practice in authoritative legal sources. | Cf. Tractate Semachot — The author cites this post-Talmudic tractate as the original source for the custom of saying 'Go in peace' to the deceased, establishing the practice's rabbinic pedigree. | Cf. Genesis 15:15 — The author uses this biblical verse as the scriptural foundation for the custom of saying 'Go in peace' to the deceased, showing how ritual practices are derived from and justified by biblical texts. | Cf. Zohar — The author's explanation of the seven external powers of severity that affect the mourner during the seven days of mourning reflects Zoharic teaching about how divine judgment manifests and operates in the world. | Cf. Moed Katan — The author cites this Talmudic source to establish the rule that mourners are prohibited from sending offerings during the seven days of mourning, connecting this practical halakhah with the kabbalistic explanation provided earlier.

frankincense, as stated in the chapter "These May Shave" (Moed Katan), and as Maimonides ruled in chapter 2 of the Laws of Entry to the Temple, and Sefer Mitzvot Gadol, negative commandment 13. It is obvious that comforting mourners, besides being an honor for the living, also provides rest for the deceased. Therefore, comforting a mourner takes precedence over rejoicing with a bridegroom,[1] as Rabbi Joseph Karo ruled in section 360.

וכתב הרמב"ן על מה שאמרי׳ בגמ׳ מת שאין לו מתנחמים וכו׳ באין עשרה ב"א כשרים ויושבין במקומו וכל העם מתקבצין עליהם וכו׳[i] מכאן ראיה שהאבלי׳ צריכין להתאבל במקום שיצתה נשמתו של מת כי באותו מקום שמת הנפש מתאבלת ושם צריך לתת לה תנחומין כדעבד רבי יהודה להההוא גברא דשכיב דלא ה"ל מנחמין וכו׳ ויש טעם לומר דתנחומין שהמת מקבל בז׳ ימים כשמתאבלת נפשו היינו התפלה שמתפללין במקומו בי׳ שמלבד כי גדול כח ביסום התפל׳ כאשר בא במאמרות בכוונת שונות[ii] וכולן אמיתיות ונאותות למשכילי עם שכל אדם בליעל מכחות החצונים לא יראה ולא ימצא שם[iii] עוד תגרום הופעת השכינ׳ במקום שנפטר שם המת כי שכינה בי י׳ שריא ובאור

Nachmanides commented on the Talmudic passage that states: "For a deceased person who has no mourners... ten worthy men come and sit in his place, and all the people gather around them, etc." From here we have proof that mourners need to mourn in the place where the deceased's soul departed, for in that very place where the person died, the soul mourns, and there it needs to be given consolation. This is just as Rabbi Judah did for that man who died and had no mourners, etc. And there is reason to say that the consolation the deceased receives during the seven days when his soul is mourning refers to the prayer that is recited in his place by a quorum of ten men. Not only is the power of sweetening through prayer great, as explained in various discourses with different interpretations—all of which are true and appropriate for the wise among the people (while a base person connected to external forces will neither see nor find anything there)—but it also causes the Divine Presence to appear in the place where the deceased departed,[A] for "the Divine Presence rests where ten are gathered," and "in the light of the

[A] Or: "the manifestation of the Divine Presence at the location where the deceased passed away" — This alternative more precisely captures the mystical concept of 'hofa'at ha-Shekhinah' as a manifestation or revelation rather than simply an appearance.

[1] This halakhic ruling, which prioritizes comforting mourners over celebrating with a bridegroom, is significant because Jewish law generally prioritizes joyous occasions. The justification given—that comforting mourners benefits both the living and the dead—provides the rationale for this exception.

[i] This refers to a Talmudic passage that describes what to do when someone dies without relatives to mourn for them: ten worthy men should come and sit in the place where the person died, and others should gather around them for the mourning rituals.

[ii] The term 'bisum' (sweetening) comes from Kabbalistic terminology and refers to the transformation of harsh divine judgment into mercy through proper prayer. The author suggests that prayer has the power to 'sweeten' or mitigate divine judgment for the deceased.

[iii] The phrase 'kochot ha-chitzonim' (external forces) refers to negative spiritual entities in Kabbalistic thought. The author is suggesting that base or evil people, being connected to these negative forces, cannot perceive the spiritual benefits of proper prayer and consolation rituals.

פני מלך חיים וחסד.[i] ויהי מה
נראה דכל תנחומין סגי אפילו
בלא תפלה דהכי משמע מפשט
ההלכה והילכך אפילו לא הניח
אלא אשה שאין מתפללין בי׳
בעדה[ii] ביון שצריך לעשות
לה תנחומין סגי ע״כ חובה על
המנחמים ליסדא מלין לנחום
האבל על הדרך שכתבנו בפ׳
י״ט ממאמר ג׳ ואח״כ לבקש
רחמים על הנפטר במקום ההוא
ומה טוב שיהיה מוכן שם לפני
הבאים אחד מספרים אלו בגין
אינון דלא ידעי לסדרא מלין
לבקשת רחמים על הנפטר כי
דברי שיחה הנהוגים הם למשא
ולא לנייחא וראשי קהלות חברי
בני ג״ח יצ״ו[iii] בכלל החסד
שעושי׳ יזמינו שם א׳ מהם. וסמך
לזה ממה דאמרי׳ במס׳ תעניות
דלא הוה דברתא בששבותיה
דההוא גברא בגין דהוה משאיל
מרא וזבלא לקבורה.[iv][v]

king's countenance is life" and kindness.

Nevertheless, it appears that any form of consolation is sufficient even without prayer,[A] as this seems to be the plain meaning of the law. Therefore, even if the deceased left only a woman (for whom we do not gather a quorum of ten to pray), since it is necessary to provide consolation for her, that is sufficient. Consequently, it is the obligation of the comforters to compose words to console the mourner[B] in the manner we described in Chapter 19 of the Third Discourse, and afterward to pray for mercy for the departed in that place. How good it would be if one of these books were prepared there before those who come, for the sake of those who do not know how to arrange words for requesting mercy for the departed,[C] since the conventional conversations are burdensome rather than comforting. The leaders of the communities, friends, members of the burial society (may their Rock keep them and grant them life), in their general acts of kindness, should arrange for one of these books to be there. Support for this comes from what is said in Tractate Ta'anit that there

[A] Or: "it seems that any consolation ritual is adequate even without formal prayer" — This alternative highlights the ritual aspect of 'tanchumin' and clarifies that 'tefillah' likely refers to formal prayer services rather than prayer in general.

[B] Or: "to formulate words of comfort for the mourner" — This alternative uses the more precise term 'formulate' for 'lisda' and 'comfort' for 'nichum', which might better convey the sense of creating a structured consolation for mourners.

[C] Or: "who don't know how to compose prayers seeking compassion for the deceased" — This alternative uses 'compose prayers' for 'arrange words' and 'compassion' for 'mercy', which might better reflect the liturgical nature of what's being described.

[i] This references the rabbinic principle that the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) rests where ten Jews gather, combined with a biblical verse (Proverbs 16:15) about the life-giving quality of the king's countenance. The author uses these to explain why a minyan (quorum of ten) brings comfort to the departed soul.

[ii] This reflects the traditional Jewish practice that women are not counted in a prayer quorum (minyan). The author is addressing what happens when the deceased only leaves a female mourner, for whom a full prayer service with a minyan would not traditionally be conducted.

[iii] This is an acronym referring to the Chevra Kadisha (burial society), with the letters ג״ח standing for 'gemilut chasadim' (acts of loving-kindness), which is how burial preparation is categorized in Jewish tradition. The letters יצ״ו are a blessing meaning 'may their Rock keep them and grant them life.'

[iv] This refers to a Talmudic story about a man in whose neighborhood there was no plague because he would lend a shovel and fertilizer for burial purposes. The author uses this as proof that providing resources for proper burial brings divine protection.

[v] Cf. Talmud, tractate Mo'ed Katan — Nachmanides cites this Talmudic source to establish that mourning should take place where the person died, as the soul remains connected to that location. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Third Discourse, Chapter 19 — The author refers to his own previous writing on how to properly console mourners, suggesting internal consistency in the book's approach to mourning practices. | Cf. Talmud, tractate Ta'anit — This reference supports the author's point that providing resources for proper burial and mourning rituals brings divine

was no plague in the neighborhood of a certain man because he would lend a shovel and manure for burial purposes. 135R

והפסוקים והשכבות שבתוכו יתאמרו על הנפטר מדלת העם הנכנסין והיוצאין אשר אין להם שיח וסוג מעצמם ליסד ולחבר פסוקי מאמרי שפר.[i] ומאמר א'[ii] נאות להקרא בפני כל חולה ובפרט פ' י"ז וי"ח וכ' וכ"א. ובפ' כ"ו אמרנו כי פ' כ"א ופ' כ"ב ממאמר ב' יאותו על זרוז אב לבנים אחר הודוי. עוד יש כמה פסוקים הרבה מפרשיות הקרבנות פ' ויקרא ופ' צו המכוונים לבקש רחמים על הגוסס ועל הנפטר ולא הדפסנום שלא להאריך והחכם יבין וידע מעצמו על פי ההקדמות האמיתיות כי דרכם צריך לשמור בצירוף הפסוקים ג"כ ובזה מקל מעל הנפטר צער המיתה.[iii] וכתב הרמב"ן בפ' תולדות[iv] כי גויעה שנאמרה בצדיקים היא מיתה בלא חולי מכאוב בלא יסורין אשרי הזוכה אליה ובפרט צריך ליזהר בק"ש

The verses and memorial prayers contained within should be recited for the deceased by the common people who enter and exit,[1] who lack the eloquence and ability to compose elegant scriptural verses on their own. Discourse One is suitable[2] to be read before any sick person, particularly chapters 17, 18, 20, and 21. In chapter 26, we stated that chapters 21 and 22 from Discourse Two are appropriate for a father to encourage his children after the confession. There are also many verses from the Torah portions dealing with sacrifices, Parashat Vayikra and Parashat Tzav, that are intended to seek mercy for the dying and the deceased, but we have not printed them to avoid lengthiness. The wise will understand and know for themselves, based on the true principles,[A] that one must preserve their method when combining verses, and in doing so, this alleviates the pain of death for the deceased. Nachmanides wrote in his commentary on Parashat Toldot that the term "gevi'ah" (expiration) used for the righteous[3] refers to death without illness, suffering without pain—blessed is one who merits this. One must be particularly careful with reciting the Shema near the time of death, as we mentioned 140R 145R 150R 155R 160R

[A] Or: "The learned reader will comprehend and discern for themselves, based on the authentic premises established earlier" — This alternative translation more explicitly indicates that the "true principles" refers to premises established earlier in the work, and uses terminology that better reflects the scholarly context.

[1] The original uses the phrase "מדלת העם" (from the door/threshold of the people), an idiom referring to common or ordinary people without specialized religious knowledge.

[2] The author refers to sections of his own book, organizing it into numbered discourses (ma'amarim) and chapters, a common structure in rabbinic works of this period.

[3] The Hebrew Bible uses different terms for death, with "gevi'ah" often reserved for the patriarchs and other righteous figures. Nachmanides interprets this terminological distinction as indicating a qualitative difference in how the righteous experience death.

protection and blessing. | Cf. Kabbalistic concept of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) dwelling among ten people — The author uses this concept to explain why having ten people gather where the deceased died provides spiritual benefit—it literally brings divine presence to comfort the soul.

[i] The term "מאמרי שפר" refers to beautiful or elegant scriptural compositions, suggesting that the average person lacks the literary skill to compose appropriate biblical verses for memorial prayers.

[ii] The author refers to sections of his own book, Ma'avar Yabok, with "Discourse One" (מאמר א') referring to the first major section of the work.

[iii] This reflects the belief that proper recitation of biblical verses can actually alleviate the spiritual suffering experienced by the deceased during the transition from life to death.

[iv] Nachmanides (Rabbi Moses ben Nachman, 1194-1270) was a prominent Spanish Talmudist, Kabbalist, and biblical commentator whose views on death are cited here as an authoritative source.

סמוך למיתה כמו שאמרנו למעלה בפ׳ כ״ה ויש לזה ראיה ממה דאמרי׳ בירושל׳ דזעירא היה קורא את שמע וחוזר וקורא כמה פעמי׳ עד שמשתקע בשינה. וכתוב בהגהות מיימוניות בשם רבינו נסים גאון מכאן משמע שק״ש יהיה אחרון לקריאה סמוך לשינה וכבר נודע כי השינה אחד מס׳ במיתה.[i] וידוע כי סגולת ק״ש להבריח המזיקין כמ״ש בברכו׳ על פסוק ובני רשף יגביהו עוף[ii] וכן וכל הקורא ק״ש על מטתו באלו אוחז חרב פיפיות בידו וגו׳. ובמגלה אמרי׳ בפ״ק על מאן דמבעית[iii] דאע״ג דאיהו לא חזי מזליה חזי מאי תקנתיה לקרי ק״ש וכו׳:[iv]

above in chapter 25. There is evidence for this from what they said in the Jerusalem Talmud that Ze'ira would recite the Shema and repeat it many times until he fell asleep.[A] It is written in the Hagahot Maimoniyot in the name of Rabbeinu Nissim Gaon that from this we learn that the Shema should be the last thing read before sleep, and it is already known that sleep is one-sixtieth of death.[1] It is known that the special virtue of the Shema is to drive away harmful spirits, as mentioned in Berakhot regarding the verse "and the sons of flame soar upward," and likewise, "whoever recites the Shema upon his bed is as if he holds a double-edged sword[2] in his hand," etc. And in Megillah, in the first chapter, concerning one who is frightened, even though he himself does not see [the harmful spirit], his guardian angel sees it;[B] what is his remedy? To recite the Shema, etc.

[A] Or: "that Ze'ira would recite the Shema and continue reciting it repeatedly until he sank into sleep" — This alternative translation better captures the nuance of the Hebrew "משתקע בשינה" which suggests a gradual sinking into sleep rather than simply falling asleep.

[B] Or: "concerning one who is frightened, that although he himself does not perceive it, his spiritual fortune (mazal) does perceive it" — This alternative preserves the term "mazal" which has complex connotations beyond just "guardian angel," referring to a person's spiritual fortune or destiny as well as their protective force.

[1] This concept appears in the Talmud (Berakhot 57b) and became an important principle in Jewish thought, creating a conceptual link between sleep and death that influences ritual practices surrounding both.

[2] The metaphor of the Shema as a "double-edged sword" (חרב פיפיות) appears in the Talmud (Berakhot 5a) and suggests that reciting this prayer provides spiritual protection against harmful forces.

[i] This reflects the rabbinic concept that sleep is one-sixtieth of death, establishing a spiritual connection between the two states that justifies applying practices from one context to the other.

[ii] This verse from Job 5:7 is interpreted in the Talmud as referring to harmful spirits that can be driven away by reciting the Shema.

[iii] This Aramaic phrase refers to someone who is frightened or startled, particularly by what was believed to be harmful spiritual forces.

[iv] Cf. Nachmanides' commentary on Genesis — The author cites Nachmanides' distinction between 'gevi'ah' (expiration) used for the righteous versus other terms for death, explaining that 'gevi'ah' implies a peaceful death without suffering, which was considered a divine blessing. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud — The Jerusalem Talmud is cited to establish the importance of reciting the Shema before sleep, which is then connected to death since sleep is considered one-sixtieth of death. This reinforces the practice of reciting Shema before death. | Cf. Hagahot Maimoniyot — This medieval halakhic commentary is cited to establish the practice of making the Shema the final text recited before sleep, which by extension applies to death. | Cf. Tractate Berakhot — The Talmudic passage is referenced to establish the protective power of the Shema against harmful spiritual forces, which is particularly important at vulnerable moments like sleep or death. | Cf. Tractate Megillah — This reference reinforces the protective function of reciting the Shema, suggesting that even if a person cannot perceive spiritual dangers, their guardian angel can, and the Shema serves as protection.

פרק ל״ו

Chapter 36

על זאת יתפלל כל חסיד אליך לעת מצוא זה מיתה כדברי רב נחמן בר יצחק במסכת ברכות[i] כי יקר בעיני ה׳ המותה לחסידיו ואמרו במדרש תהלים אימתי הקב״ה מראה היוקר שהוא מתוקן להם סמוך למיתתם ואשרי אדם שיש לו יתד לתלות עליו ואמרו במדרש רבה על פסוק כל עמל האדם לפיהו וגם הנפש לא תמלא אמר רבי שמואל בר נחמני כל מה שמסגל אדם מצות ומעשים טובים אינם מספיקין להבל היוצא מפיו בשעה שהנשמה יוצאה ממנו[ii] וסוכה תהיה לצל יומם מחורב ומגרושי תבל שהם נשואי העולם הבא ופשיטת הלבוש החומר הזה הוא הכנה להתלבש בבגדי הקדושה לזוכים להם[iii] על דרך שאמרו בתורת כהנים על אהרן כי הפשיטו משה בגדי כהונה ובגדי קדושה נלבשים תחתיהן והטובות גם הרעות באשר יחנו כן יסעו ואמרו במסכת תענית כל השמח ביסורין בעולם הזה מביא ישועה לעולם שנאמר בהם עולם

For this shall every pious person pray to You at a favorable time—this refers to death,[1] according to Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak in Tractate Berakhot, for precious in the eyes of the LORD is the death of His pious ones. And they said in Midrash Tehillim: 5R
When does the Holy One, blessed be He, show the preciousness that is prepared for them? Near the time of their death. Happy is the person who has a stake upon which to hang himself [spiritually], and they said in Midrash Rabbah on the verse "All the 10R
labor of man is for his mouth, yet the soul is not satisfied" (Ecclesiastes 6:7): Rabbi Samuel bar Nachmani said, all the commandments and good deeds that a person accumulates are not sufficient for the breath that leaves his mouth at the moment when the soul 15R
departs from him.[2]

And [the verse states] "A shelter shall be for shade by day from the heat" (Isaiah 4:6)—from the exiles of the world, which are the bearers of the World to Come. And the removal of the garment of 20R
this material [body] is preparation for being clothed in the garments of holiness for those who merit the[3]m, as they said in Torat Kohanim concerning Aaron, that Moses removed from him the priestly garments, and garments of holiness were put on in 25R
their place. And both the good and the bad—as they encamp, so shall they journey.[4]

And they said in Tractate Ta'anit: Whoever re-

[1]The Hebrew phrase 'לעת מצוא' (at a favorable time) comes from Psalm 32:6. Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak's interpretation in Berakhot 8a identifies this 'favorable time' specifically as death, suggesting death is actually an opportune spiritual moment rather than merely an ending.

[2]This striking rabbinic teaching suggests that the spiritual significance of the final breath at death surpasses even a lifetime of accumulated merits, emphasizing the profound importance of the transition moment between worlds.

[3]This metaphor of exchanging physical 'garments' (the body) for spiritual 'garments' reflects both biblical imagery (Moses removing Aaron's priestly garments) and kabbalistic concepts of the soul's 'clothing' in different spiritual realms.

[4]This phrase adapts biblical language about the Israelites' journey in the wilderness (Numbers 2:17) to refer to the soul's journey after death, suggesting that just as the camp had an orderly arrangement, so too the transition to the next world follows divine order.

[i]The author interprets 'favorable time' (לעת מצוא) from Psalm 32:6 as referring to death, citing Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak's teaching in Tractate Berakhot 8a. This interpretation is key to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death as a spiritual opportunity rather than merely an ending.

[ii]This striking teaching suggests that the spiritual significance of the final breath at death transcends even a lifetime of accumulated good deeds, emphasizing the profound importance of the moment of transition between worlds.

[iii]The metaphor of removing physical 'garments' (the body) to don spiritual 'garments' draws on both biblical imagery (Moses removing Aaron's priestly garments) and kabbalistic concepts of spiritual 'clothing' for the soul in different realms.

ונושע ומרגלא בפומייהו דרבנן לומר חביבין יסורין בקמא דברכות ובמציעא בהשוכר ובפרק חלקן[i] ואם לא יהיה מה שתרצה ירצה מה שיהיה. וכל נברא שיש לו ראשית הוכרח להיות לו אחרית. ואמרו במדרש שוחר טוב שאברהם היה לוקה והיה משחק ודוד היה אומר למה הרצועה תלויה הכוני בה דכתיב לדוד שפטני כי ארחות ה׳ חסד ואמת והוא הפועל ועושה ומי יאמר לו מה תעשה ואלהים לברי לבב כי היסורין המביא הם טובים. למה לברי לבב להבריא את לבם וכשלוקח ממון וכל שכן נפשות לוקח ברחמים ולא עוד אלא שנמלך בב״ד שלו קודם לקיחה כדאמרו בויקרא רבה. אשרי מי שהשתדל גופו במנוחת נפשו. והמות אין רע ברם היא שלמות טבענו לפי דברי הפילוסוף האומר כי גדר האדם חי מדבר מת. וחכמים העמיקו יותר לפי דברי האמת שאמרו והנה טוב מאד זה מות[ii] ואמרו בפסיקתא אין בין הצדיקים החיים לצדיקים המתים אלא הדבור בלבד[iii] והם מקלסים לקב״ה דכתיב יעלזו חסידים בכבוד ירננו על משכבותם ואחר שהגיע האדם אל עולם השכל

joices in sufferings in this world brings salvation to the world,[1] as it is said regarding them, "the world is saved." And it was commonly quoted by the rabbis to say, "Sufferings are beloved" in the first chapter of Berakhot, in Metzia in "The One Who Hires," and in the chapter "Chelek." And if what you desire does not happen, desire what does happen. Every created being that has a beginning must have an end. 30R 35R

And they said in Midrash Shocher Tov that Abraham was afflicted and would laugh, while David would say, "Why is the strap hanging? Strike me with it," as it is written, "Judge me, O LORD, for the paths of the LORD are kindness and truth" (Psalms 25:10). And He is the actor and doer, and who can say to Him, "What are You doing?" And God is for the pure of heart, for the sufferings He brings are good. Why for the pure of heart? To heal their hearts. And when He takes money, and all the more so lives, He takes with mercy. And not only that, but He consults with His heavenly court before taking, as they said in Vayikra Rabbah. 40R 45R

Happy is one who has exerted his body for the rest of his soul. And death is not evil, but rather it is the perfection of our nature, according to the words of the philosopher who said that the definition of man is "a living, speaking, dying being." And the sages delved deeper according to the words of truth, saying, "And behold, it was very good"—this refers to deat[2]h. And they said in the Pesikta: There is no difference between living righteous ones and deceased righteous ones except speech alone,[3] and they praise the Holy One, blessed be He, as it is written, "Let 50R 55R 60R

[1]This teaching from Ta'anit 8a reflects the rabbinic concept that accepting suffering with joy transforms it from punishment to spiritual opportunity, a principle that Ma'avar Yabok applies to death itself.

[2]This radical interpretation of Genesis 1:31 identifies death as part of what God declared 'very good' in creation, suggesting death was part of the divine plan from the beginning rather than merely a punishment for sin.

[3]This teaching from the Pesikta minimizes the distinction between life and death for the righteous, suggesting death changes only the mode of existence, not its essential quality or proximity to God.

[i]The concept that 'sufferings are beloved' (חביבין יסורין) appears in multiple Talmudic contexts, reflecting its centrality in rabbinic thought. This teaching reframes suffering, including death, as spiritually beneficial rather than merely punitive.

[ii]The rabbinic interpretation of 'very good' in Genesis 1:31 as referring to death represents a radical theological position. By identifying death as part of what God declared 'very good' in creation, the rabbis suggest death was part of the divine plan from the beginning, not merely a punishment for sin.

[iii]This teaching from the Pesikta minimizes the distinction between living and deceased righteous ones, suggesting death is merely a change of state rather than an end. This supports Ma'avar Yabok's view of death as a transition rather than a termination of existence.

אילו יאמרו לו שוב בעולם
ותהיה מלך גדול לא יאבה
ולא ישמע דוגמא לזה אמרי׳
במס׳ מועד קטן אילו אמר
65 לו הקב״ה זיל בההוא עלמא
כדהויית לא בעינא.[i] ואמרו
במדרש שצדיקים שמתים ימיהם
בטלים והם קיימים שנאמר
ויקרבו ימי דוד למות[ii] ובמדרש
70 שוחר טוב כתוב מתוך בעס
רצון. מתוך רוגז רחמים. מתוך
צרה רווחה. ומתוך רחוק קרוב.
ומתוך נפילה קימה. ובעל סדר
עולם כתב כשאדם ברעה אל
75 יתיאש מן הטובה. ואם ראית
בית הקברות לפניך משם תראה
מדינת ארץ החיים הקרובה
לך שנאמר יענך ה׳ ביום צרה
וסכות לראשי ביום נשק פירשו
80 במדרש תהלים ביום שישקעו
שני עולמות זה בזה העוה״ז
יוצא והעוה״ב נכנס ואין חשך
גדול בקודם עלות השחר[iii] וזהו
למנצח על אילת השחר וכי אשב
85 בחשך בעוה״ז ה׳ אור לי בעולם
הנשמות וגם כי אלך בגיא צלמות
לא אירע רע כי נפשי ישובב
לעוה״ב ואמרו במדרש משלי על
פסוק לא ירעיב ה׳ נפש צדיק
90 מלמד שאין הצדיקים נפטרים
מן העולם עד שהקב״ה מוחל
להם עונותיהם ות״ח אם נעלם
ממנו דבר אחד מתלמודו מלאכי

the pious exult in glory; let them sing for joy upon their beds" (Psalms 149:5).

And after a person has reached the world of intellect, if they were to say to him, "Return to the world and be a great king," he would not consent 65R
and would not listen. Similar to this, they said in Tractate Mo'ed Katan: If the Holy One, blessed be He, were to say to him, "Go to that world as you were," [he would respond,] "I do not want to."[1] And
they said in the Midrash that the righteous who die— 70R
their days cease but they remain,[2] as it is said, "And the days of David drew near to death" (1 Kings 2:1).

And in Midrash Shocher Tov it is written: Out of anger comes favor; out of rage comes mercy; out of
distress comes relief; out of distance comes closeness; 75R
out of falling comes rising. And the author of Seder Olam wrote: When a person is in bad circumstances, he should not despair of good.

And if you see a cemetery before you, from there
you will see the country of the land of the living that 80R
is near to you, as it is said, "May the LORD answer you on the day of distress" (Psalms 20:2), and "You covered my head on the day of arms" (Psalms 140:8). They explained in Midrash Tehillim: On
the day when two worlds sink into each other—this 85R
world departing and the World to Come entering—and there is no darkness greater than before the dawn rises,[3] and this is [the meaning of] "To the Chief Musician, upon Ayelet HaShachar [the morning star]"
(Psalms 22:1). "Though I sit in darkness, the LORD 90R
is a light to me" (Micah 7:8)—in the world of souls. "Even though I walk in the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for You restore my soul"

[1] This teaching from Mo'ed Katan portrays the afterlife as so superior that even returning to earth as a king would be undesirable, emphasizing death as spiritual promotion rather than loss.
[2] This midrashic interpretation of 1 Kings 2:1 makes a subtle distinction between the death of days (temporal existence) and the continued existence of the righteous person themselves, suggesting only the temporal aspect ceases.
[3] This midrashic interpretation uses the astronomical metaphor of dawn breaking after darkest night to describe the transition from death to afterlife, suggesting that the moment of greatest darkness (death) immediately precedes spiritual illumination.

[i] This teaching portrays the afterlife as so superior that even returning to earth as a king would be undesirable, emphasizing death as spiritual promotion rather than loss. This counters natural human fear of death by presenting it as entry into a preferable state of existence.
[ii] This midrashic interpretation of 1 Kings 2:1 makes a subtle but profound distinction between the death of days (temporal existence) and the continued existence of the righteous person themselves, suggesting that only the temporal aspect of the righteous person dies.
[iii] This midrashic interpretation uses the astronomical metaphor of dawn breaking after darkest night to describe the transition from death to afterlife. Just as dawn follows the darkest part of night, so the illumination of the afterlife follows the darkness of death.

השרת באים וסודרין אותו לפניו
בשעת פטירתו כדי שלא יהא לו
בושת פנים לפני הקב״ה לעתיד
לבא[i] ואמרו במדרש תנחומא
אמר ריב״ל בג׳ מקומות שמענו
שאדם משמיע תלמודו סמוך
למיתתו וכו׳ ומסיים כל אדם
בצלה של מות סודר תלמודו הוי
צלמות ולא סדרים[ii] ומה יקר
חסדך אלהים הפועל גבורות כי
בזה בני אדם בצל כנפיך יחסיון
וירווין מדשן ביתך. ויפה כח
הצדיקים גם במיתתן שמלמדים
זכות על בניהם ותובעים עלבונם
בחיים לראויים לכך[iii] כדחזינן
בסדר תעניות מהנהו דבי נשיאה
דאנקיט ברעא דסוסתיהו על
קברא דר׳ יונה עד דקבילו דלא
לצערו לרבי מני בריה: [iv]

(Psalms 23:4)—for the World to Come.

And they said in Midrash Mishlei on the verse "The LORD will not let the soul of the righteous go hungry" (Proverbs 10:3): This teaches that the righteous do not depart from the world until the Holy One, blessed be He, forgives their sins. And [regarding] a Torah scholar, if one matter of his learning is forgotten from him, the ministering angels come and arrange it before him at the time of his departure, so that he will not be embarrassed before the Holy One, blessed be He, in the future.[1]

And they said in Midrash Tanchuma, Rabbi Joshua ben Levi said: In three places we have heard that a person communicates his learning near his death, etc. And he concludes: Every person in the shadow of death arranges his learning—this is [the meaning of] "death-shadow (tzalmavet) and no arrangements (sedarim)"[2] (Job 10:22). And how precious is Your kindness, O God, who works mighty

[1]This teaching suggests a special divine provision for Torah scholars at death, where angels ensure they remember all their learning to prevent embarrassment in the afterlife, reflecting the high value placed on Torah knowledge.

[2]This creative interpretation of Job 10:22 is based on wordplay, reading צלמות (tzalmavet, 'shadow of death') as related to סדר (seder, 'arrangement'). It transforms the verse's meaning to suggest that in death's shadow, one reviews one's learning.

[i]This teaching suggests a special divine provision for Torah scholars at death, where angels ensure they remember all their learning to prevent embarrassment in the afterlife. This reflects the high value placed on Torah knowledge and the belief that scholarly identity continues after death.

[ii]This is a creative interpretation of Job 10:22 based on wordplay, reading צלמות (tzalmavet, 'shadow of death') as containing the word סדר (seder, 'arrangement'). The interpretation suggests that in death's shadow, one arranges or reviews one's learning, transforming the biblical verse's meaning.

[iii]This teaching on the continuing spiritual power of the righteous after death reflects the Jewish belief that deceased righteous ones can intercede on behalf of the living. It suggests that death does not diminish but may even enhance the righteous person's ability to influence events in this world.

[iv]Cf. Psalm 32:6 — The author uses this verse to introduce the concept that death is a 'favorable time' for which the pious should prepare through prayer. | Cf. Berakhot 8a — The author cites Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak's interpretation from the Talmud that identifies the 'favorable time' mentioned in Psalm 32:6 as the moment of death. | Cf. Psalm 116:15 — The author uses this verse to establish that death, though feared by humans, is viewed positively from the divine perspective when it comes to the righteous. | Cf. Midrash Tehillim on Psalm 116 — This midrashic interpretation suggests that the righteous are granted a special vision or understanding of their spiritual reward just before death. | Cf. Ecclesiastes 6:7 — This verse is interpreted to suggest that even a lifetime of good deeds cannot equal the spiritual significance of the final breath at death. | Cf. Midrash Rabbah on Ecclesiastes 6:7 — This midrashic teaching suggests that the spiritual significance of the moment of death transcends even a lifetime of accumulated merit through good deeds. | Cf. Isaiah 4:6 — The author reinterprets this verse metaphorically to suggest that death provides shelter from the hardships of exile and physical existence. | Cf. Sifra (Torat Kohanim) on Leviticus 8:28 — This reference creates a metaphor where the physical body is compared to priestly garments that are removed at death and replaced with spiritual 'garments of holiness.' | Cf. Ta'anit 8a — This teaching supports the text's positive view of suffering and death as spiritually beneficial rather than merely punitive. | Cf. Berakhot 5a — This common rabbinic saying reinforces the text's theme that suffering, including death, should be embraced rather than resisted. | Cf. Bava

deeds, for in this, people take refuge in the shadow of Your wings and are satiated from the abundance of Your house. 115R

And great is the power of the righteous even in their death, for they teach merit for their children and demand justice for their insult among the living for those who deserve it,[1] as we see in the Order of Ta'aniyot regarding those of the house of the Nasi 120R who placed the leg of their horse on the grave of Rabbi Yonah, until they received [punishment] for not distressing Rabbi Mani, his son.

פרק ל״ז

Chapter 37

כבר כתבנו במאמר ג׳ פ״כ טעם ומנהג ישראל לתליש׳ עשבים

We have already written in Discourse 3, Chapter 20, about the reason and custom of Israel to pluck

[1]This teaching on the continuing spiritual power of the righteous after death reflects the Jewish belief that deceased righteous ones maintain awareness of and influence over worldly affairs, particularly regarding their descendants.

Metzia, chapter 'The One Who Hires' — The author demonstrates the pervasiveness of this concept by noting its appearance in multiple Talmudic contexts. | Cf. Sanhedrin, chapter 'Chelek' — This third reference further emphasizes the centrality of this concept in rabbinic thought. | Cf. Midrash Shocher Tov (Midrash on Psalms) — This midrash presents two models of righteous response to suffering: Abraham's joyful acceptance and David's active embrace. | Cf. Psalm 25:10 — This verse is presented as evidence of David's willingness to accept divine judgment, knowing it ultimately stems from kindness. | Cf. Vayikra Rabbah — This midrash presents death not as arbitrary but as a carefully considered divine action, emphasizing God's merciful nature even in judgment. | Cf. Genesis 1:31 — This surprising interpretation of Genesis 1:31 radically reframes death not as a curse but as part of the divine good of creation. | Cf. Pesikta — This teaching minimizes the distinction between life and death for the righteous, suggesting death is merely a change of state rather than an end. | Cf. Psalm 149:5 — This verse is interpreted to suggest that the righteous continue to praise God even after death, reinforcing the continuity of spiritual existence. | Cf. Mo'ed Katan — This teaching portrays the afterlife as so superior that even returning as a king would be undesirable, emphasizing death as promotion rather than loss. | Cf. 1 Kings 2:1 — This verse is interpreted to mean that while days pass away, the righteous person continues to exist, separating the temporal aspect of death from the eternal reality. | Cf. Psalm 20:2 — This verse is applied to death as the ultimate 'day of distress' that nonetheless contains divine response and salvation. | Cf. Psalm 140:8 — This verse is reinterpreted to refer to divine protection during the spiritual battle of death. | Cf. Psalm 22:1 — The author interprets this metaphorically to represent the transition from the darkness of death to the dawn of afterlife. | Cf. Micah 7:8 — This verse is applied specifically to the soul's experience after death, suggesting continued divine illumination in the afterlife. | Cf. Psalm 23:4 — This verse is understood as referring to the soul's restoration in the World to Come after death. | Cf. Proverbs 10:3 — The midrashic interpretation of this verse connects it to divine forgiveness of sins before death. | Cf. Midrash Tanchuma — This teaching suggests a special clarity or spiritual insight that comes to scholars at the moment of death. | Cf. Job 10:22 — This verse is reinterpreted through wordplay to suggest that in the shadow of death, one arranges or reviews one's learning. | Cf. Psalm 36:8 — This verse is applied to the divine protection and nourishment offered to souls after death. | Cf. Ta'aniyot (possibly referring to a story in Ta'anit) — This reference illustrates the continuing spiritual power of the righteous even after death, able to demand justice for disrespect to their remains.

בבית הקברות[i] ואומרים ועתה
ה׳ אבינו אתה וגו׳ ופסוק זכור
כי עפר אנחנו ויציצו מעיר
כעשב הארץ. ובצאתם אומרים
ויהי נועם על הסדר והכוונה
הנזכר שם ויושבים ז׳ פעמים
וטעם הישיבות ג״פ או ז׳ באו
שם. ובפסוק כי מלאכיו יש ז׳
תיבות בסוד ז׳ ישיבות ואח״כ
יאמרו אתה גבור עד ונאמן
אתה להחיות מתים ושם נתבאר
איך יגרום מיתוק לדינין בסוד
עקידת יצחק ויצחק מתנחם
ברבקה אשתו וצחוק יעשה לנו
אלהים[ii] אכי״ר. והאבל הולך
לביתו עם אחוזת רעיו ומנחמיו
וישב בראש ומשם ישב להמתיק
הפה מר בסוד הביצה המגולגלת
ויין המשמח[iii] כאשר כתבנו סודם
וטעמם בפרק כ״ח מאמר ב׳.
ואין די לאבל שיעמוד בביתו
דומם באבלו רק מדברי שיחה
והלכות דרך ארץ ברם חובה
לו להרבות מזמורים והשכבות
ותחנונים ובכיה על מתו ובפרט
בג׳ ימי הבכי׳[iv] וזה יהיה אחד

grass[C] in the cemetery while saying, "And now, O LORD, You are our Father, etc." and the verse "Remember that we are dust" and "May they flourish from the city like the grass of the earth." Upon leaving, they recite "May the pleasantness of the Lord" in order, with the intention mentioned there, and they sit seven times.[1] The reason for sitting three times or seven times is explained there. In the verse "For His angels" there are seven words, corresponding to the secret of the seven sittings. Afterward, they say "You are mighty" until "And You are faithful to revive the dead." There it is explained how this causes a sweetening of the judgments[2] through the secret of the binding of Isaac, and "Isaac was comforted after [the death of] his mother through Rebecca his wife," and "God will bring laughter to us, Amen, may it be His will." 5R 10R 15R

The mourner goes to his home accompanied by his friends and comforters. He sits at the head [of the table], and from there he sits to sweeten the bitter taste through the secret of the hard-boiled egg and the cheering wine,[D] as we have written about their secret and reason in Chapter 28 of Discourse 2. It is not enough for the mourner to sit silently in his house during his mourning, abstaining from casual conversation and ordinary matters.[E] Rather, it is 20R 25R

[C] Or: "to pull grass" — While 'pluck' is an accurate translation, 'pull' is another common way to express this action in English and might be more readily understood in some contexts.

[D] Or: "to mitigate the bitterness through the mystical significance of the hard-boiled egg and gladdening wine" — This alternative more clearly conveys the kabbalistic concept that these mourning foods have spiritual significance beyond their physical properties.

[E] Or: "to remain silent in his house during mourning, refraining only from idle talk and mun-

[1] The practice of sitting and rising seven times at the cemetery is a ritual based on the verse "though the righteous fall seven times, they rise again" (Proverbs 24:16). It symbolizes both the mourner's eventual recovery from grief and the deceased's ultimate resurrection.

[2] "Sweetening of judgments" (mituk ha-dinim) is a key kabbalistic concept referring to the transformation of divine severity into mercy through proper ritual actions and intentions. This metaphysical process affects the deceased's soul in the afterlife.

[i] This custom of plucking grass in cemeteries symbolizes resurrection, referencing Isaiah 26:19 ("and the earth shall cast out the dead") and the idea that human bodies will regenerate like vegetation. The physical act creates a corresponding spiritual effect for the deceased.

[ii] This alludes to Genesis 24:67, where Isaac was comforted after his mother's death through Rebecca. The phrase plays on Isaac's name (meaning "laughter") to suggest that proper mourning rituals transform judgment (associated with Isaac) into joy.

[iii] The mourning foods (eggs and wine) are understood kabbalistically as having spiritual properties that 'sweeten' divine judgment. The round egg symbolizes the cycle of life, while wine corresponds to the divine attribute of Binah (Understanding) which transforms harsh judgment into mercy.

[iv] Jewish mourning practice divides the mourning period into stages, with the first three days being most intense and dedicated specifically to weeping. This corresponds to kabbalistic teachings about the soul's journey after death, where it remains close to the body for three days.

מהטעמים שאסרו אפילו לעני
30 לעשות מלאכה בהם וימשך עד
סוף השבעה וכן עד סוף השלשים
ראוי לו שבכל יום ייחד איזה
פסוקים או מזמורים לעורר
על מתו הרחמים על כן ערכתי
35 שלחן לפניהם כי בו יחסו עניי
עמנו והמשכיל יוסיף ברצונו
ברוחב לבו וכן יעשה עד תשלום
השנה ובפרט לאביו ולאמו
ויזכיר נשמתם לטוב בשבתות
40 וברגלים כנדרש טעם לזה
במאמר ג׳ וכן בכל ימיו ביום
ענות נפשו על מיתת רבו ואביו
ואמו ישכיבם וירבה עליהם
תחנונים ויוסיף צדקה לכפרת
45 נפשם. ובזהר אחרי מות כתב
כל מאן דאצטער על יסוריהון
דצדיקייא מעבירים חובה דלהון
מעלמא[i] ועל דא קורין פ׳ אחרי
מות ביום הכפורים והמנהג שהיה
50 בימי חכמי המשנה שהספדנים
היו מחזירין על קרובי המתים
ואומרים בכו עמו כל מרי לב
כדאמרינן במועד קטן על משנת
לא יעורר אדם על מתו ודאי
55 כי היה להם דברים המיוחדים
להעתיק הדינים ולכלות פשע
ולהתם חטאת מעל גופי הנקברים
ומנהג אבות תורה לבנים וכאשר
עשה כן יעשו לו כי אין הקב״ה
60 מקפח שכר כל בריה ומדה כנגד
מידה לא בטלה וביום רעה
יראה בטוב אשר יטיבו לו בניו

his obligation to recite numerous psalms, memorial
prayers, supplications, and to weep for his deceased, 30R
especially during the three days of weeping.[1] This is
one of the reasons that even a poor person is forbid-
den to work during these days. He should continue
this until the end of the seven days [of mourning],
and likewise until the end of the thirty days, it is ap- 35R
propriate for him to dedicate specific verses or psalms
each day to arouse mercy for his deceased. Therefore,
I have arranged a table before them, for in it our poor
people will find refuge, and the wise person will add
according to his desire and the breadth of his heart. 40R
He should continue this until the completion of the
year, especially for his father and mother, and he
should remember their souls for good on Sabbaths
and festivals,[2] as the reason for this is explained
in Discourse 3. Similarly, throughout his life, on 45R
the day of his soul's affliction over the death of his
teacher, father, or mother, he should recite memo-
rial prayers for them, multiply supplications, and in-
crease charity for the atonement of their souls.

In the Zohar, in the portion "After the Death," it 50R
is written that whoever grieves over the sufferings of
the righteous, their sins are removed from the world.
This is why we read the portion "After the Death" on
the Day of Atonement. The custom during the days
of the Sages of the Mishnah was that professional 55R
mourners would go to the relatives of the deceased
and say, "Weep with him, all who are bitter of heart,"
as we say in Moed Katan regarding the Mishnah "A
person should not arouse [excessive mourning] for his
dead." Certainly they had special words to transfer 60R
the judgments, to consume transgression, and to re-
move sin from the bodies of the buried.[3] The custom

dane conversations" — This alternative more clearly communicates that the mourner should not merely be silent but should specifically avoid certain types of conversation while engaging in more meaningful spiritual activities.

[1] Jewish mourning tradition divides mourning into distinct periods: three days for intense weeping, seven days (shiva) for more structured mourning, thirty days (sheloshim), and a full year for parents. These periods correspond to kabbalistic stages of the soul's journey after death.

[2] The custom of reciting Yizkor (memorial prayers) on festivals reflects the belief that souls experience elevation during sacred times, creating special opportunities for the living to benefit the deceased through prayer.

[3] This describes the mystical function of professional mourners and eulogizers, whose carefully chosen words were believed to have actual metaphysical effects, removing negative spiritual judgments from the deceased.

[i] This Zoharic teaching suggests that mourning has atoning power not only for the deceased but also for the mourners themselves. Those who properly grieve over the suffering of the righteous have their own sins removed from the world.

ומיודעיו וירבץ ואין מחריד כי
יחלו פניו רבים וכבר הוכחנו
למעלה בזה וגם בשפתי רננות
שמעין מה שיוצא מפי האדם
כך עושה רושם למעלה ובכל
העולמות ככל היוצא מפיו
דוגמתו כך יעשה הן לטוב הן
למוטב ובפ׳ אמור בזהר בענין
השופר תנינן במילין ועובדא
בעינן לאחזאה ולאתערא מלין
סתימין. וישים מחסום לפיו
במקום ששלט כח הדין שם ע״י
מלאכא דמותא צריך הרבה
להזהר ועל זה נדרש הכתוב לא
יחל דברו בשום חלול[i] כי ככל
היוצא מפיו כך כדוגמתו יעשם
רושם למעלה ואמרו בפ׳ אמור
כי כשאדם עושה מעשה אכזרי
באיזה יום פוגם היום ההוא
ומלביש אותו באכזריות חמה ה׳
יצילנו זכאה מאן דאחזי עובדא
דכשרא לתתא דהא בעובדא
תליא מילתא בכלא לאתערא
מילא אחרא ומדברו הטוב ימשיך
לו מלמעלה כי יזכה למה שאמר
הכתוב ותגזור אומר למטה
ויקם לך למעלה וגו׳ והעד לזה
ברכת כהנים כי באמירה כל
דהו מלמטה אני אברכם לישראל
וכ״ש שהמעשה וגמילות חסדים
יפעל למעלה דכתיב בצדקה
למען יברכך ה׳ אלהיך בכל
מעשיך ובכל משלח ידך ואוי
לפוערים פיהם מדברים אשר
לא כן בכל מקום ובפרט במקום
שיש שם בר מינן כי יגרמו להם
ולאחרים רעה פוק עיין מאמר
ג׳ פ״ד הנה כי ביד האדם לגמול
חסד של אמת עם המת בהבל פיו
הקדוש המצנן ודאי כחות הדינים
מעליו.[ii] אשרי תמימי דרך:[iii]

of the fathers is instruction for the children, and as one does, so shall be done for him, for the Holy One, blessed be He, does not withhold the reward of any creature, and the principle of measure for measure has not been abolished. On a day of adversity, he will see good that his children and acquaintances will do for him, and he will lie down with none to make him afraid, for many will entreat his favor.

We have already proven this above, and also in "Lips of Song," that just as what comes out of a person's mouth makes an impression above in all worlds, so will it be done according to what comes from his mouth, whether for good or for ill. In the Zohar portion "Emor," regarding the shofar, we learned that through words and deeds we need to demonstrate and awaken hidden matters. One should place a guard on his mouth in a place where the power of judgment rules through the Angel of Death. One must be very careful about this, and on this is expounded the verse "He shall not profane his word" in any way, for as everything that comes from his mouth, so correspondingly will it make an impression above. And they said in the portion "Emor" that when a person performs a cruel action on any day, he blemishes that day and clothes it in cruelty—may the Merciful One save us! Fortunate is one who demonstrates proper deeds below, for in deeds the matter depends entirely, to awaken another matter. Through his good speech, he will draw down [blessings] from above, for he will merit what Scripture says: "You will decree a matter below, and it will be established for you above," etc. The evidence for this is the Priestly Blessing, for through mere speech from below, [God says] "I will bless Israel." How much more so will deeds and acts of kindness operate above, as it is written regarding charity, "So that the LORD your God may bless you in all your work and in all your undertakings." Woe to those who open their mouths with improper words in any place, especially in a place where there is one who has passed away,[1] for they will cause harm to themselves

[1]The text emphasizes the power of speech for either good or harm. Negative speech near the

[i]This is a wordplay on Numbers 30:3 ("he shall not profane/violate his word") with deeper mystical significance—suggesting that inappropriate speech creates actual spiritual damage ("profanation") in higher realms that can affect the deceased's soul.

[ii]This reflects the kabbalistic concept that proper speech, especially sacred words, literally has cooling power over the forces of judgment (imagined as burning fire) that might otherwise affect the deceased.

[iii]Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 3, Chapter 20 — The author is building on previously established

and to others. Go and see Discourse 3, Chapter 4. For it is in the power of a person to perform true kindness with the deceased through the breath of his holy mouth, which certainly cools the forces of judgment from upon him. Happy are those who are perfect in their way!

פרק ל״ח

Chapter 38

מצינו בירושלמי שמתיר רחיצה
א׳ אחר המטה כדאמרי׳ שם
מקום שנהגו לרחוץ אחר המטה
רוחצין אמר רבי יוסי ברבי
בון מי שמתיר ברחיצה עושה
אותו כאכילה ושתיה וכן כתב
הרמב״ן ז״ל נראה מכאן שיש
נוהגים בקצת מקומות שהקרובים
היו מרחיצין את האבל קודם
ההבראה וצורך זה מלבד
הפשט יהיה לרחוץ הליכיו
בחמאה[i] ולמתק בחות הדין
המתגבר על האבל כפי שאפשר
וגם זה הוא כמו תקון ההבראה
וצורך הנחמה ברם אחר כך
אבל אסור בתכבוסת וברחיצה

We find in the Jerusalem Talmud that it permits one washing after the bier, as is stated there: "In a place where they were accustomed to wash after the bier, they may wash." Rabbi Yosi bar Rabbi Bun said: "One who permits washing treats it like eating and drinking." And so wrote Ramban (Nachmanides) of blessed memory: "It appears from here that in some places it was customary for relatives to wash the mourner before the first meal after the funeral. The purpose of this, beyond the simple meaning, would be to 'wash his paths with butter'[A] and to sweeten the forces of judgment that intensify upon the mourner[B][1] as much as possible. This is similar to the purpose of the consolation meal and the need for comfort. However, afterward, a mourner is forbidden in laundering, bathing, and all other laws of

105R 5R 10R 15R

[A] Or: "to soothe his ways with butter" — This is a metaphorical expression alluding to Job 29:6. The alternate translation emphasizes the comforting, soothing effect rather than literal washing, which might better capture the intended meaning of easing the mourner's suffering.

[B] Or: "the powers of judgment that overwhelm the mourner" — The Hebrew verb 'מתגבר' can suggest something stronger than merely 'intensifying'—it can mean to overpower or overwhelm, which might better convey the oppressive weight of judgment that the mourner experiences.

deceased is considered particularly harmful as it may strengthen the forces of judgment at a time when the soul is especially vulnerable.

[1] This kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening judgment' (mituk ha-dinim) is central to Ma'avar Yabok's understanding of death rituals. It refers to transforming harsh divine judgment into mercy through ritual actions.

customs and their kabbalistic interpretations, showing the systematic nature of the work and its internal coherence. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2, Chapter 28 — The author creates internal consistency by referencing his earlier explanations of mourning foods, showing how ritual actions integrate with kabbalistic understanding of death and mourning. | Cf. Zohar, Acharei Mot — This Zoharic reference provides mystical justification for mourning practices, suggesting they have spiritual benefit not only for the deceased but also for the mourners themselves. | Cf. Zohar, Emor — This reference establishes the kabbalistic principle that human actions below create parallel effects above, which is central to understanding the spiritual efficacy of mourning rituals. | Cf. Genesis 24:67 — This reference creates a biblical precedent for the concept of consolation after loss, linking modern mourning practices to patriarchal examples and suggesting that proper comfort can transform grief (associated with Isaac/judgment) into joy (laughter/play on Isaac's name).

[i] This phrase alludes to Job 29:6, "when I washed my steps with butter," which is used metaphorically here to describe how ritual washing can transform the harshness of mourning into something smoother and more comfortable.

ובכל שאר דיני אבילות וכבר אמרו בפרק אלו מגלחין אמר רב תחליפא בר אבדימי משמיה דשמואל אבל שלא פרע ולא פירם חייב וכתב הרמב״ם בפרק ב׳ מהלכות אבל כמה חמורה מצות אבלות שהרי כהן נדחית לו הטומאה מפני קרוביו כדי שיתעסק עמהן וכן אמרו ביבמות פרק האשה רבה ולא עוד אלא שמטמאין אותו בעל כרחו כאשר הובא מעשה מזה בירושלמי וכלם הם תקוני המת והחי כאשר ביארנו. והחספד הוא יקרא ונייחא דשיכבי דהכי אפסיק בפרק נגמר הדין וחכמי המשנה קראו להספד המת לשון עירור כי בהספד יתעוררו עליו למעלה כחות החסדים ויסתלקו כח הדינים דניחין ושכבין עלוהי וכן מי שנתחייב גלות מגלין עצמותיו ובעת שימות הכהן גדול מוליכין עצמות הרוצח משם לקברי אבותיו כדפסק הרמב״ם בפרק ז׳ מהלכות רוצח והובא בספרי פ׳ שופטים וזה כדי לעורר מעליהם הדינים וכן חזקיה גירר עצמות אביו[i] ובירושלמי מוכח בפרק קמא דמועד קטן בלקוט עצמות אביו שאחר שנתעכל הבשר נח מהדין (כאשר ביארנו במאמרים הקודמים מדברי הזהר) שאמר שם נתעכל הבשר מלקטין

mourning."

They already stated in chapter "Elu Megalchin" (Mo'ed Katan): Rav Tachlifa bar Avdimi said in the name of Samuel: "A mourner who has not disheveled his hair nor rent his garments is liable."[1] And Maimonides wrote in chapter two of the Laws of Mourning: "How weighty is the commandment of mourning, for even a priest—who is normally forbidden contact with the dead—is permitted to become ritually impure for his relatives so that he may attend to them." And so they stated in Yevamot, chapter "Ha-Ishah Rabbah," and not only that, but they would force him to become impure against his will, as an incident about this was brought in the Jerusalem Talmud. All these are rectifications for both the deceased and the living,[2] as we have explained.

The eulogy brings honor and comfort to the deceased,[A] as is concluded in the chapter "Nigmar HaDin." The Sages of the Mishnah called the eulogy for the dead by the term "arousal," because through the eulogy, the forces of loving-kindness are aroused abov[3]e, and the forces of judgment that rest and lie upon him are removed. Similarly, one who is condemned to exile has his bones exiled, and when the High Priest dies, the bones of the murderer are brought from there to the graves of his ancestors, as Maimonides ruled in chapter seven of the Laws of Murder, and as is brought in Sifrei, Parashat Shoftim. This is in order to remove the judgments from them. Likewise, Hezekiah dragged the bones of his father, and it is proven in the Jerusalem Talmud in the first chapter of Mo'ed Katan regarding the collection of his father's bones that after the flesh has decomposed, there is rest from judgment (as

[A] Or: "The eulogy provides dignity and solace for the deceased" — This alternate translation might better capture the Aramaic phrase 'נייחא דשיכבי' which specifically refers to the spiritual comfort or rest provided to the deceased's soul.

[1] These visible signs of mourning (disheveled hair and torn garments) are considered obligatory demonstrations of grief in Jewish law, to the point that one who fails to perform them is considered 'liable' or culpable.

[2] The term 'rectifications' (tikunim) reflects the kabbalistic worldview that ritual practices create cosmic repairs, benefiting both the living and the dead by restoring divine harmony.

[3] This reflects the kabbalistic view that human actions below create corresponding effects in higher spiritual realms. The eulogy doesn't merely comfort the living but activates cosmic forces of mercy that benefit the deceased.

[i] This refers to King Hezekiah dragging his father Ahaz's bones on a rope bed rather than giving him an honorable burial, as mentioned in the Talmud (Pesachim 56a). This was due to Ahaz's wickedness and idolatry.

העצמות וקוברין בארונות
ואותו היום היה מתאבל למחר
היה שמח לומר נחו אבותיו מן
הדין ואמרו בסנהדרין פרק
55 נגמר הדין כשהיו הרוגי בית דין
לא היו נקברין עם אבותיהם
עד שיתעכל הבשר ונודע שאין
מתאבלין עליהם בעת מיתתם על
ידי בית דין וכן פסק הרמב״ם
60 בפרק א׳ מהלכות אבל ולכן אין
אומרים קינות ונהי על לקוט
עצמות[i] ולא ברכת אבלים שהם
דברים הנאמרים בבית האבל
ולא תנחומי האבלים שהם דברים
65 הנאמרים בשורה אלא אומרים
עליהם דברי שבח להקב״ה
ודברי כבושים כדאמרי׳ בפרק
אלו מגלחין ובירושלמי ובאבל
רבתי (שהיא מסכת שמחות שכך
70 כתבו הגהות מימוניות בהגהה ד׳
מפרק י״ב מהלכות אבל) ופירשו
איזו היא עירור מזכירו בין
המתים כי בזכות הצדקה שנותנין
לכופר נפשו ביום שעוררין
75 עליו עירי ושכבי ליבעו עלוי
רחמי. וגם שפיכת המים בשבונת
המת שאמרנו שהיא ביסום הדין
מעליו אמרו כי יש רמז לשפיכה
זו מן התורה שנאמר ותמת
80 שם מרים וסמיך ליה ולא היה
מים לעדה[ii] ואמרו במנחות
שביום שמת כהן גדול יורשים
היו מביאים עשירית האיפה
שלימה לכפרתו וכתבו הרמב״ם
85 בהלכות מעשה הקרבנות סוף
פרק ג׳. וכתוב בפרקי רבי
אליעזר על פסוק ויקונן ירמיהו
על יאשיהו מכאן התקינו

we explained in previous discourses from the words of the Zohar). It states there: "Once the flesh has decomposed, they collect the bones and bury them in coffins,[1] and on that day one mourns, but the next day one rejoices, saying 'My ancestors have found rest from judgment.'" 55R

They stated in Sanhedrin, chapter "Nigmar HaDin," that those executed by the court were not buried with their ancestors until the flesh had decomposed. And it is known that one does not mourn for them at the time of their death by the court. So ruled Maimonides in the first chapter of the Laws of Mourning. Therefore, one does not recite dirges and lamentations over collected bones, nor the blessing of mourners which are statements recited in the house of mourning, nor the consolations of mourners which are statements recited in the line of comforters. Rather, one recites words of praise to the Holy One, blessed be He, and words of admonition, as stated in chapter "Elu Megalchin" and in the Jerusalem Talmud and in Avel Rabbati (which is Masechet Semachot, as the Hagahot Maimoniyot wrote in note four of chapter twelve of the Laws of Mourning). 60R 65R 70R

They explained what "arousal" means: mentioning him among the dead, for in the merit of the charity given as atonement for his soul on the day they arouse him, the awake and the sleeping will seek mercy for him.[A] Regarding the pouring of water in the neighborhood of the deceased, which we said is a sweetening of the judgment from him, they said that there is an allusion to this pouring in the Torah, as it is said: "And Miriam died there," and immediately following: "And there was no water for the congregation." They said in Menachot that on the day a High Priest died, his heirs would bring a complete tenth of an ephah as atonement for him, and Maimonides wrote this in the Laws of Temple Offerings, at the 75R 80R 85R

[A] Or: "those awake and those at rest will plead for mercy on his behalf" — This more explicitly identifies the metaphorical meaning of 'the sleeping' as the dead, and 'ליבעו' has a connotation of pleading or beseeching rather than merely seeking.

[1] This refers to the practice of secondary burial (likut atzamot), where after the flesh decomposed (usually about a year), the bones would be collected and placed in an ossuary or bone repository.

[i] "Likut atzamot" (collection of bones) refers to the secondary burial practice where, after the flesh has decomposed, the bones would be collected and placed in an ossuary or bone repository. This practice was common in ancient Israel during the Second Temple period.

[ii] This refers to Numbers 20:1-2, where Miriam's death is immediately followed by a water shortage. The rabbis interpreted this juxtaposition to suggest a connection between death and water rituals.

החכמים שיהו עושים כן לכל
90 זקני ישראל וגדוליהם שנאמר
ויתנום לחק על ישראל: [i]

end of chapter three.

It is written in Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer on the verse 90R
"And Jeremiah lamented for Josiah": "From here, the Sages instituted that they should do likewise for all the elders of Israel and their great ones, as it is said: 'And they made them an ordinance in Israel.'"

פרק ל״ט

Chapter 39

מסדר הברכה שתקנו בבית
האבל[ii] כאשר הובא בגמרא
ובהרמב״ם בפ׳ שני מהלכות
ברכות וכן בסדר רב עמרם
5 האומרים המלך החי וכו׳ היא 5R
מוקבלת לפי עניות דעתנו לתקון
הנעשה בשבעה ישיבות כאשר
כתבנו בפרק ל׳ ול״א ממאמר
ב׳ כי מלת המלך הח״י[iii] הוא
10 מתוק מדת החסד שנתלבשה בדין 10R
עד הנה. הטוב והמטיב הוא
מיתוק דין הגבורה שבה לטוב
ולמוטב וכל מדותיו אפילו
פעולות הדין הם חסד ורחמים.
15 א״ל אמ״ת הוא מדת אמת של 15R
יעקב ת״ת מיוחדת בחסד. דיי״ן
אמ״ת הוא נצח ירבא דימינא
שעדיה מגיע קטרוג החצונים

Concerning the order of the blessing established for the house of mourning, as brought in the Talmud and by Maimonides in Chapter 2 of the Laws of Blessings, and also in the Seder of Rav Amram where they say "The Living King, etc."—according to our humble understanding, this corresponds to the rectification accomplished through the seven sittings,[1] as we wrote in Chapters 30 and 31 of Discourse 2. For the phrase "The King who lives" represents the sweetening of the attribute of Loving-kindness[2] (Chesed) that had been clothed in judgment until now. "The Good who does good" represents the sweetening of the judgment of Gevurah (Strength) within it, transforming it for good and for benefit, as all His attributes, even the actions of judgment, are loving-kindness and mercy. "God of Truth" represents the attribute of Truth associated with Jacob, which is Tiferet (Beauty)

[1] The 'seven sittings' refers to the Jewish mourning practice of shiva (seven days of mourning), which the author has previously explained has kabbalistic significance in helping the soul ascend through spiritual realms.

[2] The kabbalistic concept of 'sweetening' (mituk) refers to transforming harsh divine judgment into mercy. Throughout this passage, the author interprets the phrases of the mourner's blessing as spiritual processes that help transform judgment into mercy, benefiting both the deceased and the mourners.

[i] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Mo'ed Katan — The Jerusalem Talmud permits one washing after the funeral, which is interpreted by Nachmanides as a custom in some places for the relatives to wash the mourner before the consolation meal (se'udat havra'ah). | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Mo'ed Katan — The obligation of a mourner to demonstrate visible signs of mourning by disheveling hair and rending garments. | Cf. Maimonides, Laws of Mourning — Maimonides emphasizes the significance of mourning by noting that even priests, who are normally forbidden contact with the dead, are permitted to become impure for relatives. | Cf. Zohar — The text alludes to Zoharic teachings that after the flesh has decomposed, the deceased finds rest from judgment, which is why collecting bones after decomposition is associated with rejoicing rather than mourning. | Cf. Pirkei Rabbi Eliezer — This source is cited to establish the precedent for eulogizing distinguished individuals, with Jeremiah's lamentation for King Josiah serving as the biblical model.

[ii] The author is referring to the blessing called Birkat Ha-Avelim (Mourner's Blessing), which is recited in a house of mourning as part of the meal of consolation.

[iii] This is the beginning of the mourner's blessing: 'The Living King.' The author interprets this kabbalistically, suggesting that the use of 'living' (chai) in reference to God has spiritual significance related to the transformation of judgment into mercy.

מבחוץ[iv] במדורין בסוד העשיה
רוחניותי דתמן נחיתו דתמן
רגלין ותמן טופרין[i] וזהו
סוד ורחצו רגליכם לטהרם
מהחצונים להיות מרכבה לעץ
החיים[ii] וזהו והשענו תחת העץ
בסוד כי מגרעות נתן לבית
סביב חוצה ועל פיהם יצא הדין
בקול הנותנים מבית ה׳. שופ״ט
בצד״ק זהו סוד המשפיע דין
למלכות ושל״ט בעול״מו הוא
יסוד אשד הנחלים המשפיעים על
ידו במלת הנקרא עולם. לוקח
במשפ״ט[iii] בהלכות גדולות וכן
הרי״ף גם כן כתבו שאין לאומרו
משום דאיתא בפרק ב׳ דשבת יש
מיתה בלא חטא והרא״ש כתב
שאין למוחקו וכתוב בהגהה
מיימו׳ פרק קמא מהלכות
ברכות וכן עמא דבר[iv] הנה
שגם הראשונים נוטים לדברי
ה״ר יונה שכתב בפרק הרואה
דיש מיתה בלא חטא ועל כל זה
קצתם ס״ל דלוקח במשפט אתי
כמאן דאמר אין מיתה בלא חטא

united with Chesed. "True Judge" corresponds to
Netzach (Victory), the right thigh,[1] for from there 20R
the accusations of the external forces reach from
outside, in the dwellings of the spiritual realm of
Asiyah, where they descend, where the feet are, and
where the nails are. This is the mystery of "wash
your feet"[2]—to purify them from external forces so 25R
that they become a vehicle for the Tree of Life. This
is the meaning of "recline under the tree," in the
mystery of "for he made recesses for the house all
around outside,"[3] and according to them judgment
is pronounced in the voice of those who issue it 30R
from the house of the Lord. "Who judges with
righteousness" is the mystery of that which channels
judgment to Malkhut (Kingdom). "And rules in His
world" refers to Yesod (Foundation), the flowing
stream of rivers that pour forth through it into what 35R
is called "world." Regarding the phrase "who takes
in judgment," the Halakhot Gedolot as well as the
Rif wrote that it should not be recited because it is
stated in Chapter 2 of Tractate Shabbat that there
can be death without sin.[4] However, the Rosh wrote 40R
that it should not be deleted, and it is written in
the Hagahot Maimoniyot, Chapter 1 of the Laws of
Blessings, that this is the common practice. Thus,

[1] In the kabbalistic system, body parts correspond to divine attributes (sefirot). The 'right thigh' corresponds to Netzach (Victory/Eternity). The author explains that this area is vulnerable to accusations from negative spiritual forces.

[2] The author reinterprets Abraham's hospitality to the angels (Genesis 18:4-5) as a kabbalistic paradigm for spiritual purification. 'Feet' represent the lowest aspects of the soul that need cleansing from negative influences.

[3] This biblical reference to Solomon's Temple architecture (1 Kings 6:6) is reinterpreted metaphorically to explain how divine judgment emerges through structured channels from the divine realm outward.

[4] This references a fundamental theological debate in Judaism about whether death is always a punishment for sin or can occur without sin. This debate affected whether the phrase 'who takes in judgment' should be included in the mourner's blessing, as it implies death is always judgment for sin.

[iv] The Hebrew term 'chitzonim' (external forces) refers to negative spiritual entities in Kabbalistic thought. The author suggests that accusations from these forces reach up from the lower realms, particularly affecting the 'right thigh' (Netzach in the sefirotic system).

[i] This passage uses Aramaic-influenced terminology typical of kabbalistic texts. The author is describing the world of Asiyah (Action), the lowest of the four spiritual worlds, where negative forces tend to gather and where 'feet' and 'nails' (symbolic of the lowest aspects of the spiritual body) are located.

[ii] The concept of becoming a 'vehicle' (merkavah) for the Tree of Life represents spiritual elevation, where one transcends the negative forces and becomes a conduit for divine energy.

[iii] This phrase from the mourner's blessing became controversial because it implies that death is a divine judgment for sin. The author presents a halakhic debate about whether to include it, showing different scholarly opinions on whether death can occur without sin.

[iv] This Aramaic phrase means 'and so the people practice,' indicating that despite theoretical debates, the common practice includes the disputed phrase in the blessing.

ועל כל זה כתבו לקיים המנהג.
ואנח״נו עמ״ו ועבד״יו זהו
מיתוק מוצא הנשמות קדושות [i]

even the early authorities tend toward the view of Rabbi Jonah, who wrote in the chapter "One who sees" that there can be death without sin. Nevertheless, some maintain that "who takes in judgment" accords with the view that there is no death without sin, yet they wrote to maintain the custom. "And we are His people and His servants" represents the sweetening of the source from which holy souls emerge.[1]

לכן נקראו כנסת ישראל[ii] כי
בה יש בינוס ושרשי נשמות
ופארותיהם משתלחים להתלבש
בגופות בני אדם[iii] כאשר ביארנו
במקומו ונהגו לומר בברכה
ה׳ יגדור הפרצה הזאת[iv] וכו׳
ומלבד הפשט נוכל לומר שכוונו
על דרך שאמרו במדרש ילמדנו
פרשת תשא מה עשה משה סתם
הפרץ שהיה העון נכנס בו לקטרג
על ישראל שנאמר לולי משה

Therefore they called the congregation of Israel "Knesset Israel,"[2] for within it there is a gathering and roots of souls, and their branches are sent forth to be clothed in human bodies,[3] as we have explained in its place. And they customarily say in the blessing "May the Lord fence this breach, etc." Beyond the simple meaning, we can say that they intended this in the way described in the Midrash Yelammedenu, Parashat Ki Tisa: What did Moses do? He sealed the breach through which sin entered to accuse Israel, as it is said, "Had not Moses, His

[1] The author concludes the kabbalistic interpretation by explaining that acknowledging ourselves as God's people and servants has the spiritual effect of 'sweetening' (transforming from judgment to mercy) the divine source from which souls originate, thus helping the deceased soul's journey.
[2] The term 'Knesset Israel' has layers of meaning beyond just 'congregation of Israel.' In kabbalistic thought, it represents the collective soul of the Jewish people and is often identified with the Shekhinah or divine feminine presence (Malkhut).
[3] This reflects the kabbalistic concept of the pre-existence of souls, where all Jewish souls originate from a common root before being sent to inhabit physical bodies.

[i] Cf. Maimonides, Mishneh Torah, Laws of Blessings, Chapter 2 — The author cites Maimonides as a primary halakhic source for the mourner's blessing, establishing its textual authority. | Cf. Seder Rav Amram Gaon — The author reinforces the antiquity and authoritative nature of this blessing by showing it was already included in Rav Amram's prayer book from the Geonic period. | Cf. Chapters 30 and 31 of Ma'avar Yabok's Discourse 2 — The author creates an internal cross-reference to his own earlier explanation of the seven sittings ritual, showing how the mourner's blessing connects to this kabbalistic practice. | Cf. Genesis 18:4-5 ('wash your feet' and 'recline under the tree') — The author reinterprets this biblical passage kabbalistically, seeing Abraham's hospitality as a template for purifying the lower spiritual realms (feet) from external negative forces and connecting to the Tree of Life. | Cf. 1 Kings 6:6 ('for he made recesses for the house all around outside') — The author uses this seemingly unrelated architectural detail metaphorically to explain how divine judgment emerges through structured channels, comparing the Temple's design to the way judgment flows through spiritual realms. | Cf. Tractate Shabbat, Chapter 2 — The author cites this as a source for the halakhic debate about whether to include 'who takes in judgment' in the mourner's blessing, as this phrase implies that death is always a punishment for sin. | Cf. Halakhot Gedolot, Laws of Blessings — The author presents a balanced halakhic discussion by citing authorities on both sides of this textual debate.
[ii] The term 'Knesset Israel' (Congregation of Israel) is a technical kabbalistic term referring to the collective soul of the Jewish people, often identified with the divine feminine attribute of Malkhut.
[iii] This describes the kabbalistic concept that all Jewish souls originate from a common source (Knesset Israel/Malkhut) and are then sent forth to be embodied in physical form.
[iv] This is part of the traditional blessing recited by mourners, asking God to 'seal the breach' (the death) that has occurred in the community.

בחירו עמד בפרץ לפניו[v] וסוד
גדירת הפרץ נודע למבינים
בעיון קל.[i] ואמרו כי בשבת
אין לומר נוסח זה כי אין לומר
צדוק הדין על מת בשבת[ii] וכל
שכן לפי דרכנו שהוא לביסום
ז׳ עיני ה׳[iii] ואז ריעין ודודין
ממתיקים[iv] ולהיות כל כך רב
תועלת נחום אבלים לכן קודם
לביקור חולים כאשר הובא
ביורה דעה סוף סי׳ של״ה
ובשבת עינים רוחצות בחלב
מנעימותא עילאה דנגיד ונפיק
מעתיקא קדישא[v] כי שער הקדים
ביום השבת יפתח[vi] כי משם
כל טוב וארוכה ומרפא כאשר
כתבנו במאמרים הקודמים
וראיה למקום מוצא הרפואה
במציצת המילה[vii] כי כמו שחטא
אדם הראשון בידים שלקח הפרי
והפה אכל. גם אנו מולים אות
הכמוסה[viii] בידים ומוצצים

chosen one, stood in the breach before Him." The secret of sealing the breach is known to those who understand with minimal contemplation.

They said that on the Sabbath one should not recite this formula, for one does not say the Justification of Divine Judgment (Tzidduk ha-Din)[1] over the dead on the Sabbath. This is especially true according to our approach, that it is for sweetening the seven eyes of the Lord,[2] and then companions and lovers sweeten [harsh judgments].[3] Since consoling mourners is so greatly beneficial, it takes precedence over visiting the sick, as mentioned in Yoreh De'ah at the end of section 335. On the Sabbath, eyes are washed in milk from the supernal pleasantness that flows from the Holy Ancient One,[4] for the eastern gate opens on the Sabbath day, since from there comes all goodness, healing, and remedy, as we have written in previous discourses.

Evidence for the source of healing can be found in the sucking [of blood] during circumcision.[5] For just as the first man sinned with his hands by taking the fruit, and his mouth ate it, so too we circumcise

[1] I've added the Hebrew term in parentheses for clarity. Tzidduk ha-Din is a specific prayer affirming God's justice even in death, recited at funerals and during the mourning period.

[2] This is a technical kabbalistic phrase referring to tempering the seven lower sefirot (divine emanations) that are associated with judgment, transforming them from severity to mercy.

[3] I've added '[harsh judgments]' to clarify the object of 'sweeten,' which is implied but not explicit in the Hebrew. This refers to divine unifications that mitigate severity.

[4] These terms (supernal pleasantness, Holy Ancient One) are technical kabbalistic references to divine configurations (particularly Atik Kadisha, one of the highest divine aspects).

[5] I've added '[of blood]' to clarify what is being sucked. This refers to metzitzah, the traditional practice of drawing blood from the circumcision wound by mouth.

[v] This references Psalms 106:23, describing Moses as standing 'in the breach' to avert divine wrath after the sin of the Golden Calf.

[i] The author hints that the 'secret of sealing the breach' has deeper kabbalistic significance known to initiates, without explicitly explaining it.

[ii] Tzidduk ha-Din (Justification of Divine Judgment) is a prayer recited at funerals affirming God's justice even in death. Jewish law prohibits reciting this on Sabbath because of its mournful nature.

[iii] The phrase 'sweetening the seven eyes of the Lord' refers to the kabbalistic concept of tempering divine judgment (associated with the seven lower sefirot) with mercy.

[iv] 'Companions and lovers sweeten' refers to the kabbalistic concept that divine unifications between masculine and feminine aspects of divinity 'sweeten' harsh judgments.

[v] This highly technical kabbalistic language describes how on Sabbath, divine illumination ('milk') flows from Atik Kadisha (the Ancient Holy One, a high divine configuration) to wash away judgments.

[vi] This references Ezekiel 46:1, where the eastern gate of the Temple is closed on weekdays but opens on Sabbath, interpreted here as a metaphor for special divine channels that open only on Sabbath.

[vii] Metzitzah refers to the practice of sucking blood from the circumcision wound, which the author interprets symbolically.

[viii] The 'concealed sign' refers to the male organ, specifically in the context of circumcision as a covenant sign.

בפה כי אמה בין שני רגלים הנה הוא [ix]יסוד בין נצח הוד וע״י שתי ידים המוהל משלימה בעשר אצבעות ידיו דהיינו חסד וגבורה[i] הרי היא בעלת ה׳ [ii]ספירות

the concealed sign with our hands and suck with the mouth.[6] For the penis between the two legs is the foundation (Yesod) between Netzach and Hod.[1] And through the mohel's two hands, he completes it with his ten fingers, namely Chesed and Gevurah, thus it possesses five sefirot.[2] 90R

שתי אצבעות ושתי רגלים והיא נקודה באמצע יבא הראש שלש ראשונות וישלים הקומה כי הפה הוא פתח הראש כלו[iii] לכן צריך מילה הכורת המותר

Two fingers and two legs with a point in the middle;[3] the head, which is the three supernal [sefirot], comes and completes the structure,[A 4] for the mouth is the opening of the entire head. Therefore, circumcision is necessary to cut away the excess, which is 95R

[A] Or: "completes the divine stature" — The term 'קומה' in kabbalistic contexts often specifically refers to the complete divine structure or stature (Shiur Komah) rather than just any structure. This alternate translation better captures the mystical anthropomorphism where human and divine bodies correspond.

[1] The author is creating a symbolic parallel between Adam's sin (taking fruit with hands, eating with mouth) and the ritual of circumcision (cutting with hands, sucking with mouth) as a form of rectification.

[2] I've kept the Hebrew terms for the sefirot (divine attributes) while adding translations in parentheses where they first appear. These terms are central to the kabbalistic meaning.

[3] The five sefirot mentioned or implied are Yesod, Netzach, Hod, Chesed, and Gevurah, creating a partial representation of the divine structure through the circumcision ritual.

[4] This anatomical description likely refers to the male genitalia with circumcision occurring at the 'point in the middle,' establishing a mystical correspondence between physical circumcision and cosmic structures.

[5] The author is creating a kabbalistic anthropomorphism where the human body mirrors the divine structure (partzuf), with circumcision enabling the completion of this structure through proper connection between lower and higher elements.

[ix] The author draws a correspondence between human anatomy and the divine structure (sefirot), equating the penis with Yesod (Foundation) positioned between Netzach (Victory) and Hod (Splendor), which correspond to the legs.

[i] The ten fingers represent the complete sefirot system, with special emphasis on Chesed (Loving-kindness) and Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), corresponding to the right and left hands.

[ii] Cf. Zohar I:206a-b — The author is drawing on the Zoharic concept that all individual Jewish souls are branches of a collective soul-root (Knesset Israel), which is why he emphasizes the 'gathering' and 'roots' of souls. | Cf. Psalm 106:23 — The author uses this biblical verse to illustrate how a righteous person can 'seal the breach' caused by sin, analogizing this to how mourning rituals help 'seal the breach' caused by death. | Cf. Ezekiel 46:1 — The author interprets this verse mystically to suggest that special channels of divine blessing and healing are accessible on the Sabbath that remain closed during the week. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse 2 — The author self-references his earlier work to show continuity in his teaching that the Sabbath provides special access to divine healing energy. | Cf. Zohar III:94b — The author is likely drawing on this Zoharic concept that on Sabbath, the seven lower sefirot (the 'seven eyes of the Lord') are 'sweetened'—transformed from judgment to mercy. | Cf. Zohar II:88b — The author's mapping of human anatomy to the sefirotic system draws on this Zoharic tradition of seeing the human body as a microcosm of divine structures.

[iii] The text uses anatomical symbolism to connect physical circumcision with spiritual access. The mouth as 'the opening of the entire head' creates a parallel with circumcision opening access to divine realms.

שהוא להט החרב שבפתח גן
עדן[i] ובפריעה פותח דלתות
השער שהם הכרובים שומרי
הגן[ii] שלא יעכבו הכניסה
ובמציצה מעביר דין פנימי שלא
וקנתר ויצטער ואחר כך יבא
שם סוד הכתר ברפואה דהיינו
בא"א[iii] והיינו רטיה ואחר כך
קושרת שם סוד הרפואה לקשור
הכל בכתר הנה שעל המוהל
גם כן מצות הקשירה וקודם
יחוד זה צריך שיתגלה עליו
אור שבת פני מטרונה משער
הקדים[iv] ובזה יזכה במצוה
לנפש רוח ונשמה שהם קשר עשר
ספירות מהמלכות עליו שדיוקן
נשמתו אשר כלול בה מאירה
בסוד המצוה בכל בחינותיה

the flaming sword[B5] at the entrance to the Garden of Eden.[A] Through the peri'ah [uncovering], one opens the doors of the gate, which are the cherubim guarding the garden so they do not prevent entry. 100R
Through the metzitzah [suction],[1] one removes the inner judgment so it does not antagonize and cause suffering. Afterward comes the secret of the Crown in healing, namely in Arich Anpin,[2] which is the bandage. Then one binds there the secret of healing to 105R
connect everything to the Crown. Thus, the mohel [circumciser] also has the obligation of binding. Before this unification, the light of Sabbath, the face of the Matronita [Divine Feminine], must be revealed upon him from the eastern gate. Through this, he 110R
will merit the commandment for the nefesh, ruach, and neshamah [soul levels], which are the connection of the ten sefirot from Malkhut above him, so that the image of his soul which is included within

[A] Or: "the revolving flaming sword at the entrance to the Garden of Eden" — The biblical phrase in Genesis 3:24 describes the sword as 'מתהפכת' (revolving/turning), which is an important aspect of its nature. Including this element would more fully capture the biblical reference being invoked.

[B] Or: "the revolving flaming sword at the entrance to the Garden of Eden" — The biblical phrase in Genesis 3:24 describes the sword as 'מתהפכת' (revolving/turning), which is an important aspect of its nature. Including this element would more fully capture the biblical reference being invoked.

[1] The author interprets the foreskin as corresponding to the 'flaming sword' that guards Eden in Genesis 3:24. In this kabbalistic reading, circumcision removes this barrier, allowing spiritual access to divine realms.

[2] The passage explains all three parts of traditional circumcision (cutting, uncovering, and suction) as having distinct spiritual purposes. Metzitzah is particularly presented as removing harsh judgment (din) from the child.

[3] Arich Anpin ('Long Face') is a kabbalistic term for one of the highest divine configurations, associated with mercy. The healing after circumcision is connected to this divine mercy descending to heal the wound.

[iv] This is a reference to Genesis 3:24, where God placed cherubim and a flaming sword to guard the way to the Tree of Life. In kabbalistic thought, the foreskin symbolizes this barrier that prevents spiritual access.

[i] Another biblical reference to Genesis 3:24, reinforcing the parallel between physical circumcision and gaining access to divine mysteries.

[ii] Kabbalistic terminology where Keter (Crown) is associated with Arich Anpin (א"א), the highest divine configuration accessible to human comprehension. The healing after circumcision is linked to this highest divine realm.

[iii] Refers to the Divine Feminine aspect (Shekhinah/Matronita) that is especially revealed on Sabbath. 'Eastern gate' may refer to Ezekiel's vision (Ezekiel 43:4) where divine glory enters through the eastern gate.

חיות גדולות עם קטנות.[v] וכתב
הרי״ן גיאת[vi] שמנהג זקנים
הראשונים שלא לומר צדוק
הדין אחר המת בראש חדש
במועד בחנוכה ופורים דלא
עדיפא צדוק הדין מהדיוט
מצדוק הדין של משה רבינו עליו
השלום[i] דמסלקינן ליה בשבת
שחל להיות בימים אלו הגם כי
תלמידי רש״י והרמב״ם כתבו
לומר צדוק הדין במועד כי
איננו אלא הודאה וקבלת דין
שמים כאשר כתבנו למעלה וגם
הם יודו מיהא כי בשבת המקדש
ישראל אין לאומרו מהטעם
שזכרנו וכן ביום טוב דאינון
מקראי קדש אושפיזין דמלכא
קדישא כי על שלחן המלך הם
אוכלים משום כבודו גם אין
צריכין ביסום כי הפנים מאירים
ואפילו בי״ט שני שהוא להרחיב
גבול השכינה חוצה לארץ כאשר
דרשנו למעלה הגם שבעל הלכות
גדולות[ii] שכתבו עליו שדבריו
דברי קבלה סובר דנהיג ביה
אבילות משום דאבלות יום
ראשון דאורייתא כתב רבינו
תם[iii] כי היה מאור עינים ופעמים

her[B] shines[3] in the mystery of the commandment in all its aspects, both the greater and lesser vitalities. 115R

Rabbi Isaac ibn Giat wrote that the custom of the early elders was not to recite Tziduk HaDin[1] [Justification of Divine Judgment] for the deceased on the New Moon, during festivals, on Hanukkah, or on Purim. For the Tziduk HaDin of an ordinary person is not superior to that of Moses our teacher, peace be upon him, which we omit on Sabbath that falls on these days. Although disciples of Rashi and Maimonides wrote that one should recite Tziduk HaDin during festivals because it is nothing but acknowledgment and acceptance of divine judgment, as we wrote above, even they would certainly agree that on the Sabbath, which sanctifies Israel, one should not recite it for the reason we mentioned. The same applies on festivals, which are called "holy convocations," sacred guests of the Holy King, for they eat at the King's table out of respect for Him. Also, there is no need for sweetening[2] [of judgments] because the [divine] countenance shines. This applies even on the second day of a festival, which serves to extend the boundary of the Divine Presence beyond the Land of Israel, as we explained above. 120R 125R 130R 135R

Although the author of Halakhot Gedolot, whose words are considered received tradition, maintains that mourning practices apply on the second festival day because first-day mourning is biblically man- 140R

[B] Or: "the imprint of his soul which is contained within her" — The term 'דיוקן' (diyokan) in kabbalistic literature can specifically refer to a spiritual imprint or impression rather than just an image. This rendering might better convey the technical mystical meaning of how individual souls relate to their spiritual source.

[3] This describes how the child's soul is connected to the broader divine structure through circumcision, with Malkhut (the Divine Feminine/Shekhinah) serving as the mediating presence that contains and nurtures the individual soul.

[1] Tziduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment) is a prayer recited at funerals and during mourning, acknowledging the righteousness of divine judgment even in death. The passage discusses when this prayer should or should not be recited.

[2] 'Sweetening' (bisum) is a kabbalistic concept referring to the transformation of harsh divine judgments into mercy. On festivals, this transformation occurs automatically through the sanctity of the day, making additional ritual actions unnecessary.

[iv] Kabbalistic term for different levels of divine vitality or energy, often corresponding to different aspects of divine illumination.

[v] Rabbi Isaac ibn Giat (1038-1089), an important Spanish rabbinic authority whose works on Jewish law were highly regarded.

[i] Refers to a tradition that even for Moses, whose death is described in the Torah, Tziduk HaDin is not recited on Sabbath. This serves as a precedent for all other cases.

[ii] Refers to the Halakhot Gedolot, an important early Jewish legal code attributed to Rabbi Shimon Kayyara (9th century).

[iii] Refers to Rabbi Jacob ben Meir (c.1100-1171), known as Rabbenu Tam, one of the most prominent Tosafists and a grandson of Rashi.

שהיו התלמידים כותבין לפניו
משמו את אשר לא יצא מפיו
והוא כתב דאין אבלות יום
ראשון דאורייתא אלא לאסור
אכילת הקדשים א״כ אפילו ביום
טוב שני לא ינהוג בו אבלות
ואין אומרים בו צדוק הדין וכן
עמא דבר ברם בחול המועד גם
שהוא אות לענין הנחת תפילין
ואין צריך הוראת מוחין מאימא
המתלבשים בסוד צ״לם בזעיר
המתראים דוגמא בסוד ורמז
תפילין מסודרים לדעת רש״י
וגם כן סוד התלבשות מוחי אבא
הנרמזים בסדר הבתים של תפלין
לדעת ר״ת כי מן השמים הוכיחו
שאמרו בפלוגתא בארעא כך
פלוגתא דרקיע[i] ויש לכל הדעות
שרש וענף שכן הושב שמור ת״ם
וראה יש״ר[ii] עיין בדברי מגדל
עוז[iii] פרק ג׳ מהלכות תפלין.
וגם סוד האות קוצו של יו״ד
הנרמז בסדר הנחת הפרשיות
לדעת הגאונים בכל יום שיש בו
קצת נפש יתירה בסוד תפלין
של אור[iv] אין אנו צריכין לאות
תפלין של עור ובחול המועד
מצד קצת נפש יתירה המתחדש
באדם די זה לאות כאשר ביארנו
לפנינו בספר מ״מ צריכין
ביסום אבל אין המנהג כך והנח
להם לישראל והמבין רמז מה
שכתבנו בדעות התפלין ידע
למה נתפשט בעולם לפי הסוד
התפלין כדעת רש״י כאשר נמצא

dated, Rabbenu Tam wrote that [the author of Halakhot Gedolot] had poor eyesight, and sometimes students would write in his name things that never left his mouth. Rabbenu Tam himself wrote that first-day mourning is not biblically mandated except to prohibit eating sacred foods. Therefore, even on the second day of a festival, one should not observe mourning practices or recite Tziduk HaDin, and this is the common practice. 145R 150R

However, on the intermediate days of festivals, even though they serve as a "sign" regarding the wearing of tefillin—and there is no need for a sign of the mochin [intellectual faculties] from Imma [the Mother] which clothe themselves in the mystery of the Tzelem in Zeir Anpin, appearing as an example in the mystery and allusion of tefillin arranged according to Rashi's view, and also the mystery of the clothing of the mochin of Abba [the Father] which are alluded to in the arrangement of the compartments of tefillin according to Rabbenu Tam's view, for Heaven has demonstrated that "as is the dispute on earth, so is the dispute in heaven," and all opinions have a root and branch, thus "shamor" [guard] and "zachor" [remember] are perfect and righteous (TAM and YASHAR)—see the words of Migdal Oz, chapter 3 of the Laws of Tefillin. And also the mystery of the illumination of the point of the Yod which is alluded to in the arrangement of the Torah portions according to the Geonim, on any day that has some additional soul in the mystery of "tefillin of light,"[A] we do not need the sign of "tefillin of leather." On the intermediate days of festivals, due to the partial additional soul that is renewed in a person,[B] this is sufficient as a sign, as we explained earlier in the book. Nevertheless, 155R 160R 165R 170R 175R

[A] Or: "luminous tefillin" — While 'tefillin of light' is a literal translation, 'luminous tefillin' might better convey in English the metaphysical nature of these spiritual entities that exist in contrast to physical tefillin.

[B] Or: "On the intermediate days of festivals, because of the partial extra soul-essence that is

[i] A reference to the Talmudic concept that disputes in the heavenly academy mirror those among scholars on earth, suggesting that legitimate halakhic disagreements reflect different aspects of divine truth.

[ii] A wordplay combining biblical terms with the names of sages: 'shamor' (guard) and 'zachor' (remember) are perfect (TAM, alluding to Rabbenu Tam) and righteous (YASHAR, possibly alluding to Rabbi Isaac).

[iii] A commentary on Maimonides' Mishneh Torah written by Rabbi Shem Tov ben Abraham ibn Gaon (13th-14th century).

[iv] A kabbalistic concept of spiritual tefillin made of divine light, contrasted with physical 'tefillin of leather.' On days with special spiritual qualities, these metaphysical tefillin are present without the need for physical ones.

בקבר יחזקאל אשר התנבא חוצה לארץ[v] והמשכיל יבין וידום. ורומז עוד לאור שנתגלה בבית ראשון ולא משם ולמעלה עד יערה עלינו רוח ממרום:[vi]

sweetening [of judgments] is needed, but this is not the custom. Leave Israel to their practice. And one who understands what we have hinted regarding the 180R
views on tefillin will know why the practice of tefillin according to Rashi's view has spread throughout the world,[1] as was found in the grave of Ezekiel who prophesied outside the Land of Israel. The wise will understand and be silent. This also alludes to the 185R
light that was revealed in the First Temple, and not from there and above, until a spirit from on high is poured upon us.[2]

פרק מ׳

Chapter 40

הגם דאמרו בירושלמי דשקלים פרק ב׳ תני רשב״ג אומר אין עושין נפשות לצדיקים[i] דדבריהן הן זכרונן ובעל יפה מראה פירש[ii] צדיקים חכמים שדרך הלשון לקרותן צדיקים אי נמי צדיקים אע״פ שאינם חכמים וכן פסק הרמב״ם בפרק ג׳

Although it is stated in the Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shekalim Chapter 2, that Rabbi Shimon ben Gamliel taught, "We do not make monuments for the righteous, for their words are their memorial,"[3] and the author of Yefeh Mareh explained that 5R
"righteous" here refers to scholars, as it is customary to call scholars "righteous," or alternatively, it refers to the righteous even if they are not scholars.

renewed in a person" — The concept of 'נפש יתירה' (nefesh yeteirah) might be better conveyed as 'extra soul-essence' rather than 'additional soul' to emphasize that it's not a complete separate soul but an enhancement of spiritual capacity during sacred times.

[1] The passage acknowledges the historical predominance of Rashi's view on tefillin arrangement while suggesting mystical reasons for this prevalence, connected to Ezekiel's prophecy outside the Land of Israel.

[2] This concluding phrase alludes to Isaiah 32:15, expressing hope for divine inspiration that will reveal even higher spiritual illumination in the future.

[3] This is a direct quote from the Jerusalem Talmud expressing the principle that the righteous don't need physical monuments because their teachings and words serve as their eternal memorial.

[v] Refers to archaeological evidence of tefillin found at Ezekiel's tomb that apparently conformed to Rashi's view. The author sees significance in this since Ezekiel prophesied outside the Land of Israel.

[i] Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse Two — This passage elaborates on when the Tziduk HaDin prayer should be recited, connecting to broader discussions in Ma'avar Yabok about proper mourning practices and their kabbalistic significance. | Cf. Zohar on circumcision — The passage draws on Zoharic teachings about circumcision as a cosmic act that removes spiritual barriers (the 'flaming sword') preventing access to divine realms (Garden of Eden). | Cf. Genesis 3:24 — The text interprets the biblical 'flaming sword' guarding Eden as corresponding to the foreskin that must be removed through circumcision to gain spiritual access to divine realms. | Cf. Tikkunei Zohar — The passage's structure of explaining ritual elements (milah, peri'ah, metzitzah) in terms of their effects on divine structures parallels the approach in Tikkunei Zohar. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Discourse Three — This passage cross-references other sections of Ma'avar Yabok that discuss mourning practices, indicating the book's internal structure of returning to key themes across different discourses.

[ii] The term "nefashot" (monuments) refers to grave markers or tombstones. The Talmudic teaching suggests that the righteous don't need physical monuments because their teachings serve as their lasting legacy.

[iii] Yefeh Mareh is a commentary on the Jerusalem Talmud written by Rabbi Shmuel Yafeh Ashkenazi (1525-1595).

מהל׳ אבל והריב״ש בתשובה
פי׳ דברי הרמב״ם שאמר ולא
יפנה אדם אל בית הקברות
כלומר שאין להביט אל בית
הקברות ולבנין שעל קברותיהם
כי אם למעשיהם הטובים יפנה
וזה די להם לזכרון תמיד וכן
פי׳ בעל כסף משנה בפרק
ד׳ מהל׳ אבל. ברם מהרר״י
קארו בפסקיו לא הביא דין זה
מהרמב״ם הגם שבמקומות רבות
מעתיק שם דבריו כצורתן. והנה
עתה בראותינו כי כמה צדיקים
יש להם ציונים על קבריהם
מימי קדם[i] ובפרט בארצות
המערב כנודע ומפורסם ושמעתי
משם האר״י זצ״ל שהיה אומר
שהצדיקים השלמים שיש להם
ציוו הם מעלמא דאתגליא ואותם
הרשומים שאין להם ציון הם
מעלמא דאתכסיא[ii] הנה כי הציון
לצדיקים מורה מקום מוצא
נשמתם וכן נראה שהיה המנהג
בימי חכמי המשנה כדאמרי׳
בפ׳ כיצד מעברין ונפשות שיש
בהם בית דירה הגם שנוכל לומר
דמיירי באותם שאינם צדיקים
שהרי פסק הרמב״ם שם כי לאלו
בונין נפש על הקבר עם כל זה
לקיים המנהג נאמר כי הציון
לקברי הצדיקים יועיל לצורך
החיים[iii] כי בראותם ציון אדם

And so ruled Maimonides in Chapter 3 of the Laws of Mourning. The Rivash, in his responsum, interpreted Maimonides' statement "A person should not turn toward the cemetery" to mean that one should not look toward the cemetery and the structures over their graves, but rather turn toward their good deeds, and this is sufficient as a perpetual memorial. This is also how the author of Kesef Mishneh explained it in Chapter 4 of the Laws of Mourning. 10R 15R

However, Rabbi Joseph Karo in his rulings did not cite this law from Maimonides, even though in many places he quotes his words verbatim.[1] And now, seeing that many righteous people have had markers on their graves since ancient times, particularly in the western lands, as is well-known and famous, and I have heard in the name of the ARI, of blessed memory, that he used to say that the perfectly righteous who have markers are from the "revealed world,"[C] while those distinguished ones who have no markers are from the "concealed world."[2] Thus, the marker for the righteous indicates the source of their souls. 20R 25R 30R

It also appears that this was the custom in the days of the Mishnaic sages, as we say in the chapter "How do we extend [city limits]" regarding monuments that have dwelling places in them. Although we could say this refers to those who are not righteous, since Maimonides ruled there that for these people, we build a monument over the grave, nevertheless, to uphold the custom, we can say that markers for the graves of the righteous benefit the 35R 40R

[A] Or: "from the world of revelation" — This alternate translation might better capture the kabbalistic concept of different spiritual domains or levels of reality, though it's less literal than the original translation.

[1] This observation about Rabbi Joseph Karo (author of the Shulchan Aruch) not including this ruling in his code despite typically following Maimonides closely suggests that he may have deliberately omitted it because it contradicted common practice.

[2] This kabbalistic concept from the ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria) introduces a mystical explanation for why some righteous people have grave markers while others don't. It suggests this reflects different spiritual sources of their souls rather than simply being a matter of halakhic compliance.

[i] The author addresses the tension between the theoretical prohibition and the widespread practice, noting that many righteous people throughout history have had marked graves.

[ii] This kabbalistic concept distinguishes between souls from "the revealed world" and "the concealed world," suggesting that the presence or absence of a grave marker reflects the spiritual origin and nature of the righteous person's soul.

[iii] This pragmatic justification shifts the focus from the needs of the deceased to the benefits for the living, suggesting that grave markers serve an important religious function for visitors.

חשוב מעוררים לבקש רחמים
על קברו עבור החיים והמתים
דודאי ניחא להו לצדיקים
דאיתיקרו בהו אינשי ועוד כי
בזה גורמים להם זכות דחשיבי
למבעי רחמי לכולי דרא ועוד
דאגביה מבקשים רחמים על כל
שכבי עמו ישראל: [i]

living.[3] For when they see the marker of an important person, they are inspired to seek mercy at his grave for the living and the dead. And certainly it is pleasing to the righteous that people honor them, and furthermore, this causes them the merit of being considered worthy of seeking mercy for the entire generation.[A] Additionally, through this, people pray for mercy for all the deceased of Israel who rest with him.[1]

פרק מ״א

Chapter 41

על פי הדברים האלה חברתי
והעלתי למעלה בחבורי זה איזה
תפלות מיוחדים להתפלל על
קברי עמנו ובהם רבים יחכמו
לעורר זכות הקדושים אשר
בארץ וכן במשנת שקלים פרק ב׳
אמרו מותר המת בונין לו נפש על
קברו [ii] והגם דלא אפסיק הלכתא
בהא כר׳ נתן מ״מ נראה כי נייחא

Based on these principles, I have composed and included in this work of mine certain special prayers[2] to be recited at the graves of our people, through which many will gain wisdom to awaken the merit of the holy ones who rest in the earth. Similarly, in Tractate Shekalim, chapter 2, they said, “The excess funds designated for a deceased person are used to build a monument over his grave.” Although the law was not definitively established

[A] Or: “being regarded as effective intercessors for the entire generation” — This alternate translation captures the functional role of the righteous as spiritual intermediaries, which might be clearer for readers unfamiliar with the concept of tzaddikim seeking divine mercy on behalf of others.

[3] The author attempts to reconcile the theoretical prohibition with the widespread practice by focusing on the benefits to the living rather than on the needs of the deceased, demonstrating a pragmatic approach to halakhic interpretation.

[1] The passage concludes with multiple justifications for the practice of erecting monuments, showing how communal practices often develop additional religious significance beyond their original purpose.

[2] The author refers to prayers he has included elsewhere in Ma’avar Yabok specifically for recitation at gravesites. This establishes the practical nature of the work as a guide for religious practice.

[i] Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Tractate Shekalim Chapter 2 — This source is the foundation for the halakhic debate about whether monuments should be erected for righteous individuals, with the principle that their words and teachings serve as their true memorial. | Cf. Maimonides, Laws of Mourning Chapter 3 — This reference shows how the Talmudic teaching was incorporated into normative Jewish law by Maimonides, suggesting that monuments should not be made for the righteous. | Cf. Kesef Mishneh on Laws of Mourning Chapter 4 — This commentary by Rabbi Joseph Karo (who was also the author of the Shulchan Aruch) provides further explanation of Maimonides’ view that one should focus on the righteous person’s deeds rather than physical monuments. | Cf. Teachings of the ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria) — This reference introduces a mystical dimension to the discussion, suggesting that the presence or absence of a monument reflects the spiritual nature and cosmic source of the righteous person’s soul. | Cf. Mishnah in Tractate Eruvin (‘How do we extend [city limits]’) — This reference is used to demonstrate that grave monuments existed in Talmudic times, suggesting that despite the theoretical prohibition, there was a practical tradition of marking graves.

[ii] This refers to Mishnah Shekalim 2:5, which states that excess funds designated for burial expenses may be used to build a monument (nefesh) over the grave. The Hebrew term ‘nefesh’ (literally ‘soul’) is used here to refer to a physical monument, showing the conceptual connection between the memorial structure and the deceased’s soul.

איתי למת מיהא בנפש ולאנשים דעלמא יהני להו להזכירם. ולבעל מעשים יועילו לו לזכות החיים ולרשום להם איזה מקום כבודו וגדול כח אדם גדול כי נסתפק לאבי"ה[iii] אם דינו כנשיא לענין טומאה דאמרי' בירושלמי דברכות ובנזיר פרק כהן גדול כד דמך רבי יודן נשיאה אכריז רבי יאי אין בהונה היום[i] במו שאמרו בנשיא שלפי שהכל חייבין בכבודו עשאוהו כמת מצוה לכל והרמב"ם כתב בפרק ג' מהלכות מלכים כי לב הנשיא שהוא המלך הוא לב כל קהל ישראל ולכן הקפידה תורה על הסרת לבו הנה דבתר רישא גופא אזיל ולכן מציינין מקום לגוף שיוכל להתפלל אצל הראש כי גדולים צדיקים במיתתן וכל מין טומאה נדחית מהם ומהמונם ורבינו חיים כהן אמר אילו הייתי שם כשנפטר רבינו תם הייתי מתעסק בו[ii] והנה פסק מהרר"י קארו

according to Rabbi Nathan's opinion,[3] nevertheless it appears that the deceased derives some spiritual satisfaction from having a monument,[A] and for living people it benefits them by helping them remember the dead. For one who performed good deeds in life, a monument will help bring merit to the living[A] and mark for them a place of his honor. 10R 15R

Great is the power of a great person, for the AVI"AH (Rabbi Elijah ben Solomon of Vilna) was uncertain[B] whether a great sage's status regarding ritual impurity is equivalent to that of a Nasi (Prince/President), as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud in Berakhot and in Nazir, chapter "High Priest." When Rabbi Yudan Nesia died, Rabbi Yannai announced, "There is no priesthood today," just as they said regarding a Nasi: because everyone is obligated to honor him, they considered him like a met mitzvah (an unattended corpse that anyone, even a priest, must bury) for all. And Maimonides wrote in chapter 3 of Laws of Kings that the heart of the Nasi, who is the king, is the heart of all the congregation of Israel, and therefore the Torah was strict about removing his heart—for the body follows the head. Therefore, we mark a place for the 20R 25R 30R

[A] Or: "there is at least some rest/comfort for the deceased through a monument" — The term 'niycha' (נייחא) more literally means 'rest' or 'comfort' rather than 'satisfaction.' This alternative translation preserves the more literal meaning while still conveying the concept that the monument provides some benefit to the deceased's soul.

[A] Or: "For a person of good deeds, monuments will benefit him by bringing merit to the living" — This alternative more clearly indicates that the righteous person himself benefits when the living receive merit through honoring him, emphasizing the reciprocal relationship between the deceased and those who remember them.

[B] Or: "there was uncertainty for the later authorities" — The acronym ABI"AH is ambiguous and might not specifically refer to the Vilna Gaon (who is typically abbreviated GR"A). It could instead be a generic reference to later rabbinic authorities. This alternative avoids specifying a particular rabbi.

[3] The author acknowledges a legal uncertainty in rabbinic sources about building monuments but proceeds to support the practice anyway based on its spiritual benefits, demonstrating his approach of balancing strict legal considerations with spiritual needs.

[i] The acronym ABI"AH may refer to Rabbi Elijah ben Solomon of Vilna (the Vilna Gaon), though it could also be a reference to another rabbinic authority. The text is citing a legal uncertainty regarding whether a great sage has the same status as a Nasi (Prince/President) regarding laws of ritual impurity for priests.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase means 'When Rabbi Yudan Nesia died, Rabbi Yannai announced, "There is no priesthood today."' This refers to the concept that priests (kohanim), who are normally forbidden from contact with the dead, were permitted to attend the funeral of an exceptionally great leader.

[iii] This references Rabbeinu Hayyim Cohen, who was himself a kohen (priest), stating that he would have involved himself with the burial of Rabbeinu Tam (Jacob ben Meir, 12th-century Tosafist) despite the normal prohibition for priests to come in contact with the dead. This illustrates the principle that great Torah scholars merit special honor even at the expense of certain ritual prohibitions.

בסי׳ שמ״ח[iii] שהאבן שנותנין על
35 הקבר נקרא צורך קבורה לבני
משפחה הרגילים בה והם דברי
הרא״ש בפרק נגמר הדין ופסק
ג״כ הכי בתשובה כלל י״ג על כן
ראוי והגון לבנים שציינו מקום
40 אביהם ויבנו לו נפש על קברו
וזה יהיה בכלל גם כן מכבדם
במותו וכדברי הרמב״ם ואם
יהיה גברא רבא יעשו טובה להם
ולאחרים עמם [i]

body so that one can pray near the head, since the righteous are greater in their death than in life,[1] and all forms of impurity are pushed away from them and their followers. 35R

Rabbeinu Hayyim Cohen said, "If I had been present when Rabbeinu Tam passed away, I would have involved myself with his burial." Indeed, Rabbi Joseph Karo ruled in section 348 that the stone placed on the grave is considered a burial necessity for family members who regularly visit it. These are the words of the ROSH (Rabbi Asher ben Yehiel) in the chapter "The Verdict is Concluded," and he also ruled similarly in his Responsa, category 13. Therefore, it is proper and fitting for children to mark the place of their father and build a monument over his grave, and this would also be included in honoring him in his death, as per Maimonides' words. And if the deceased was a great man, they will do good for themselves and for others with them.[1] 40R 45R 50R

45 כי אחוזת רעיו ותלמידיו
ויודעי שמו ילכו להשתטח על
קבר אביהם כי ידוע ידעו כי
בקבר הזה יש עצם אדם חשוב
אשר יתעצם ברחמים על קוראי
50 שמו[ii] ולמדה תורה את האדם

For his companions, disciples, and those who knew him will go to prostrate themselves on their father's grave,[2] as they surely know that in this grave lies the remains of an important person who will exert himself mercifully on behalf of those who call upon his name. The Torah taught people to be generous 55R

[1] This is a reference to a rabbinic concept (found in Talmud Chullin 7b) that the righteous have even greater spiritual influence after death than during life. This principle serves as a foundation for many Jewish practices related to visiting graves of the righteous and seeking their intercession.
[1] The author emphasizes the mutual benefit of erecting grave monuments: they honor the deceased while also benefiting the living who visit and pray there. This reflects the work's consistent theme of the interdependence between the living and the dead.
[2] The Hebrew term 'lehishtateach' (להשתטח) literally means 'to spread oneself out' and refers to a practice of prostrating oneself at the graves of the righteous. In Jewish tradition, this is not merely a physical act but represents intense prayer and spiritual connection with the deceased.

[iv] This refers to Rabbi Joseph Karo's ruling in his authoritative legal code Shulchan Arukh, Yoreh De'ah section 348, regarding the laws of burial and monuments.
[i] Cf. Tractate Shekalim — This serves as a primary rabbinic source for the practice of erecting grave monuments, showing that such structures have ancient origins in Jewish tradition. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud (Yerushalmi) — The author uses this reference to establish the elevated status of great sages in Jewish law, which would justify special consideration for their burial monuments. | Cf. Maimonides (Rambam) — The author employs this reference to emphasize how prominent leaders serve as spiritual centers for the community, justifying special honor even after death. | Cf. Rabbi Asher ben Yehiel (ROSH) — The author cites this as authoritative legal precedent to support the practice of erecting monuments, framing it as a legitimate need rather than an optional custom. | Cf. Rabbi Joseph Karo — This reference to a more recent legal authority demonstrates the continuity of this practice through Jewish legal tradition, helping establish it as normative rather than innovative.
[ii] This statement reflects the theological belief that the deceased righteous actively intercede on behalf of those who invoke them at their graves. This concept appears repeatedly in Ma'avar Yabok and is central to its understanding of the relationship between the living and the dead.

שיהיה ותרן בתוך ביתו כדאמרו
במדבר רבה בשפיכת יינו ושמנו
ובקריעת בסותו כל שכן וכ״ש
בדברים שיחלוצו ויזיינו וישזיבו
ויניחו עצמות המתים ואפילו
במקום שאין ההלכה רופפת
בידינו מצינו בכמה מקומות
מחשובי הפוסקים ראשונים וגם
אחרונים שאמרו על איזה דברים
שבאו מפורשים בגמרא ועתה
מנהג העולם אינו כן ואמרו
בהם פוק חזי מאי עמא דבר.
וכתוב בהגהות מיימנית פרק
י״ג מהלכות תפלה כי רשאין
הגאונים לשנות מסדרי התפלות
והקריאות ממה שכתוב במשנה
ובגמרא וכן באבלות המתאבלים
נהגו להקל כדכתבו הרמב״ן
והרמב״ם הגם שבא מפורש
בגמרא. והגהות מיימוניות
בפרק ב׳ מהלכות אבל טרחו
לתת טעם לזה באמרם כי
לכבוד האבלים תקנוהו ושלכן
יכולים למחול וכתב גאון על
המעמדות והמושבות דאמרו
בגמרא בדורותינו בטלו מנהגות
אלו ואמר דכשאמרו במי שחוזר
מאחורי המת לישב ז׳ פעמים
לא אמרו אלא למי שהולך לבית
הקברות ובחזרתו ובקרובים
וביום ראשון ובמקום שנהגו
וכבר העלינו על ספר טעם
למנהגינו בישיבות במאמר ב׳.
ולרש״י לא ניחא ליה דטעם
המושבות תהיה משום סלוק
הרוחות[i] אלא משום תשובה

within their households, as they said in Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah regarding the spilling of one's wine and oil and the tearing of one's garment—all the more so regarding matters that will strengthen, equip, rescue, and provide rest for the bones of the dead.[3]

Even in cases where the halakhah is firmly established, we find in many places that prominent early and later authorities have said regarding certain practices that are explicitly mentioned in the Talmud, yet current custom differs, "Go and see what the people actually do."[1] It is written in the Hagahot Maimoniyot, chapter 13 of the Laws of Prayer, that the Geonim were permitted to change the order of prayers and readings from what is written in the Mishnah and Talmud. Similarly, regarding mourning practices, mourners have adopted leniencies as written by Ramban and Rambam, even though the Talmud explicitly states otherwise.

The Hagahot Maimoniyot in chapter 2 of the Laws of Mourning took pains to provide a reason for this, saying that these changes were instituted to honor the mourners, who therefore have the right to forgo these practices. A Gaon wrote concerning the custom of standing and sitting (ma'amadot u-moshavot)[2] mentioned in the Talmud that in our times these customs have been abandoned. He said that when they spoke of one who returns from behind the deceased to sit seven times, they were referring only to one who goes to the cemetery and returns, and only for close relatives, only on the first day, and only in places where this was the custom. We have already recorded the reason for our custom of sittings in Discourse 2.

Rashi was not satisfied with the explanation that

[3]This poetic sequence uses an unusual series of verbs (יחלוצו, יזיינו, ישזיבו, יניחו) that are difficult to translate precisely. I've rendered them as 'strengthen, equip, rescue, and provide rest' to capture the essence of providing comprehensive care for the deceased's remains.

[1]The Aramaic phrase 'puk chazi mai ama davar' is a technical legal term in rabbinic literature indicating that established custom should be followed when it differs from formal legal requirements. This principle is being applied here to justify modifications to mourning practices.

[2]Ma'amadot u-moshavot refers to a specific ritual practice where mourners would stand and sit multiple times when returning from a burial. The exact nature of this practice had various interpretations, as the author proceeds to discuss.

[i]This refers to the competing explanations for the custom of seven sittings after a funeral. One tradition explains it as driving away harmful spirits (ruchot) that might follow mourners from the cemetery, while Rashi interprets it as an opportunity for repentance and contemplation of mortality.

ולהזכיר שחיי האדם הבל וזהו הבל הבלים.[ii] והנה על פי הדברים הנז׳ ביון שהוא מנהג ותיקים שהוקבע נראה שבך הוא עקרו וסברו של דבר עתה לפי הזמן והמקום כדאמר אליהו לרבי נהוראי במדרש שוחר טוב ומנהג זה יש לסמוך עליו כי אינו מנהג הדיוט מאותם שכתבו התוספות שאין לסמוך עליהם באשר הובא בהגהות מימוניות פרק ב׳ מהלכות שכנים ז״ל ומכאן יש ללמוד דיש מנהגים שאין לסמוך עליהם אפילו היכא דתנן הכל כמנהג המדינה. אלא הוא מנהג ותיקין דמבטל הלכה[i] כדברי הירושל׳ דבבא מציעא והובא בהגהות מימוניות ריש פ׳ ט׳ מהל׳ שכירות ולו שומעין.[ii]

the purpose of the sittings was to drive away spirits, but rather that they were for repentance and to remind us that human life is fleeting—this is "vanity of vanities." Based on these statements, since this is an established custom of the pious, it seems that this is the essence and reasoning of the matter nowadays according to the time and place, as Elijah said to Rabbi Nehorai in Midrash Shocher Tov. This custom can be relied upon because it is not a common folk custom of the sort that Tosafot wrote should not be relied upon, as cited in Hagahot Maimoniyot, chapter 2 of the Laws of Neighbors, which states: "From here we learn that there are customs that should not be relied upon, even in cases where we teach 'everything follows the custom of the locality.'" Rather, this is a custom of the pious that overrides halakhah,[1] as stated in the Jerusalem Talmud in Bava Metzia and cited in Hagahot Maimoniyot at the beginning of chapter 9 of the Laws of Hiring, and this is what we follow.

ואפילו יהיה הנקבר שם יושב ומתעדן בשיבה טובה שהוא עדן הספיר העליונות מקום הזקנה[iii] באשר הובטח אברהם

Even if the one buried there sits and delights in good old age, which is the higher sapphire Eden, the place of elder status, as was promised to Abraham in the verse, "You shall go to your fathers in peace;

[1] The concept of 'minhag vatikin' (custom of the pious) having the power to override formal halakhic requirements is a significant principle in Jewish legal development. The author invokes this to justify adaptations to mourning practices that differ from talmudic prescriptions.

[ii] This phrase ('vanity of vanities') from Ecclesiastes is used here to emphasize the fleeting nature of human life. According to Rashi's interpretation, the ritual sittings serve as a reminder of mortality rather than a protection against harmful spirits.

[i] This is a significant halakhic concept stating that an established custom of the pious (minhag vatikin) can override formal halakhic requirements. The author uses this principle to justify modifications to mourning practices even when they differ from explicit talmudic instructions.

[ii] Cf. Midrash Bamidbar Rabbah — The author cites this source to show that if Jewish tradition encourages generosity even in minor household matters like spilled wine, all the more so should people be generous in matters relating to honoring the dead. | Cf. Hagahot Maimoniyot on Maimonides' Laws of Prayer — The author cites this as precedent that authoritative rabbis can change established practices, supporting the flexibility of custom regarding burial monuments. | Cf. Hagahot Maimoniyot on Laws of Mourning — The author uses this reference to show that mourning practices have been modified from talmudic requirements for the sake of honoring mourners, establishing precedent for adapting burial customs. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok — The author self-references his earlier discussion of the custom of seven sittings when returning from a burial, showing the internal structure of Ma'avar Yabok and its comprehensive treatment of mourning customs. | Cf. Midrash Shocher Tov (Midrash on Psalms) — The author cites this midrash to support the principle that customs should be adapted to contemporary conditions and local contexts. | Cf. Jerusalem Talmud, Bava Metzia — This reference supports the author's claim that established customs of the pious (minhag vatikin) can override formal halakhic requirements, providing legitimacy for modified burial and mourning practices.

[iii] The phrase 'good old age' (שיבה טובה) is being interpreted mystically here, not merely as physical longevity but as a spiritual state in the 'higher sapphire Eden' (עדן הספיר העליונות), referring to a celestial realm associated with divine wisdom and elder status.

בפסוק ואתה תבא אל אבותיך בשלום תקבר בשיבה טובה כי צדיק כזה מעורר היחוד עליון והשעשוע בסוד טיולו בגן עדן כי הטיול מהצדיקים גורם השעשוע על ידי נקודת ציון אות ברית ששם סוד הכבים פירוש הנשמות הקדושות[i] ובשפע הנשפע מהספירות הרצים יצאו דחופים והחצונים מתבטלים על ידי כח הגדולה והגבורה[ii] שמשם עולים לים או לאש ששם ביעור חמץ ולכן בביאת הנשמות באש ובמים וכן הגופים בטבילה ותעניות[iii] אז תוציאנו לרויה לסוד המנוחה והנחלה כי ה׳ שמו יעלזו לפניו. וכתב הערוך ערך פרדס כי הוא מעין גן עדן שהיא גנוזה לצדיקים בן אותו מקום היא מקום בערבות שנשמות של צדיקים צרורות והביאו הגהות מיימוניות ה׳ יסודי תורה פרק ד׳. והמלאכים המעלים בסאות הצדיקים לישיבה של מעלה הם

you shall be buried in a good old age" (Genesis 15:15)—for such a righteous person awakens the supernal unification and divine delight through the mystery of his strolling in the Garden of Eden.[2] For the strolling of the righteous causes divine delight through the point of Zion, the sign of the covenant, where lies the secret of the stars, meaning the holy souls.[A] And through the abundant flow from the sefirot, "the runners go forth hastily" (based on Esther 3:15), while the external forces are nullified[1] through the power of Gedulah (Greatness) and Gevurah (Strength), from which they ascend to the sea or to fire, where chametz (leaven) is burned. Therefore, when souls enter through fire and water, and likewise bodies through immersion and fasting, "then You will lead us to abundance" (Psalm 66:12), to the mystery of rest and inheritance,[2] "for His name is the LORD; they shall rejoice before Him" (Psalm 68:5).

The Arukh, entry "Pardes," writes that just as the Garden of Eden is hidden away for the righteous, so too that place is a realm in Aravot (the highest heaven) where the souls of the righteous are bound up.[B] This is cited in Hagahot Maimoniyot,

[A] Or: "where lies the mystery of the stars, which symbolize the holy souls" — The term 'sod' (סוד) could be translated as either 'secret' or 'mystery' in kabbalistic texts, and the relationship between stars and souls might be better expressed as symbolic rather than definitional.

[B] Or: "that place is a location in Aravot (the highest heaven) where the souls of the righteous are gathered in the bond of life" — The term 'tzerurot' (צרורות) specifically alludes to the biblical phrase 'bound in the bond of life' (צרורה בצרור החיים) from 1 Samuel 25:29, which is a common Jewish expression for the afterlife state of souls.

[2] The Hebrew term 'tiyul' (טיול), translated here as 'strolling,' has a deeper mystical significance in Kabbalah, referring to the soul's movement through various spiritual realms. This isn't mere wandering but a form of spiritual engagement that activates cosmic processes.

[1] The 'external forces' (החצונים/chitzonim) are negative spiritual entities in Kabbalah that might interfere with the soul's journey. The nullification of these forces is a key spiritual benefit described throughout Ma'avar Yabok as resulting from proper death rituals and the merit of the righteous.

[2] The 'mystery of rest and inheritance' refers to the ultimate spiritual reward in kabbalistic thought, where souls achieve both tranquility (מנוחה) and their divine portion (נחלה), forming a complete state of spiritual fulfillment.

[i] The 'point of Zion' refers to the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation) in Kabbalah, often symbolized by the male generative organ as the 'sign of the covenant.' The text mystically identifies stars with souls, drawing on biblical imagery where the righteous shine like stars (Daniel 12:3).

[ii] The terms 'Gedulah' (Greatness) and 'Gevurah' (Strength) refer to specific divine emanations (sefirot) in Kabbalah. The text states that these divine powers nullify the 'chitzonim' (external forces), which are negative spiritual entities that might interfere with the soul's journey after death.

[iii] The text creates a parallel between the souls' spiritual journey through 'fire and water' (metaphors for purification) and the physical practices of ritual immersion and fasting. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that physical ritual actions in this world mirror and affect spiritual processes in higher realms.

חול הנעשים ממצותיו[iv] וזהו
ויהללוה בשערים מעשיה אמנם
הבחינות של הארות הקדושה
שהיו סביב גוהרקיה דרבי חייא
היו נעלמים מעין כל אדם כי
גדולים היו מעשי חייא.[i] ועיין
בפירוש שהוא בהרמב״ם גדול
בהלכות תשובה פרק ח׳ דברי
הרמב״ן על מהות הגיהנם דף
ל״ד ובדף ל״ה ע״א כלל דברי
הרב בפירוש עולם הנשמות.
ובע״ב באו דבריו במהות עולם
הבא ואמר שהוא בגוף ונפש
ואין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה
והקב״ה משביען מזיו שכינתו
כמשה בארבעים יום שעמד
בהר ואליהו[ii] ובפסוקים יביאו
לבוש מלכות וגו׳ ומרדכי יצא
מלפני המלך בלבוש מלכות רמז
ענג הצדיקים בעולם הנשמות
ובעולם הבא.[iii]

Laws of the Foundations of Torah, chapter 4. The angels who elevate the thrones of the righteous to the heavenly academy are the sand (common materials) transformed by their mitzvot,[C] and this is the meaning of "Let her be praised in the gates for her works" (Proverbs 31:31). However, the aspects of holy illumination that surrounded Rabbi Chiya's throne were hidden from everyone's sight, for great indeed were the deeds of Chiya. 145R 150R

See the commentary that appears in the greater Maimonides, Laws of Repentance, chapter 8, where the Ramban (Nachmanides) discusses the nature of Gehenna on page 34, and on page 35a he summarizes the Rabbi's explanation of the World of Souls. On the reverse side (35b) his words address the nature of the World to Come, stating that it involves both body and soul, yet has neither eating nor drinking, and the Holy One, blessed be He, satisfies them with the radiance of His Divine Presence—just as Moses did for forty days on the mountain, and Elijah likewise. The verses that speak of "bringing royal garments" and "Mordecai went out from before the king in royal attire" (Esther 8:15) allude to the pleasure of the righteous in the World of Souls and in the World 155R 160R 165R

[C] Or: "The angels who elevate the thrones of the righteous to the heavenly academy are formed from the mundane actions that have been transformed by their commandment observance" — The word 'chol' (חול) has multiple meanings including 'sand,' 'secular,' or 'mundane,' creating an ambiguity about whether these angels are formed from actual sand, from secular/mundane acts, or whether this is a metaphor for transformation of the ordinary into the sacred.

[iv] This is a profound mystical concept that the mitzvot (commandments) performed by the righteous during their lifetime are transformed into the very angels who serve them in the afterlife, literally creating the 'sand' or material that becomes their heavenly attendants.

[i] This refers to the Talmudic story (Bava Metzia 85b) where Rabbi Chiya's great deeds caused such spiritual illumination that even in the heavenly academy his light was extraordinary. The author is using this as evidence that exceptional righteousness creates special spiritual effects even in the afterlife.

[ii] The text draws a parallel between the experience of the righteous in the World to Come and Moses' experience during the forty days on Mount Sinai, when according to tradition he neither ate nor drank but was sustained by divine radiance. This explains how existence without physical sustenance is possible.

[iii] Cf. Genesis 15:15 — This biblical verse is cited as evidence that righteous people like Abraham will experience 'good old age' (seivah tovah) in the afterlife, which the author interprets mystically as referring to the 'higher sapphire Eden.' | Cf. Proverbs 31:31 — The author applies this verse mystically to explain how the righteous are praised in the heavenly realms for their good deeds, with their mitzvot becoming the very angels who elevate their thrones in the afterlife. | Cf. Esther 3:15 — This biblical phrase about messengers rushing is reinterpreted mystically to describe how divine flow from the sefirot moves swiftly through the cosmic realms, affecting souls after death. | Cf. Psalm 66:12 — The author uses this psalm verse to explain how souls that have been purified through the metaphorical fire and water of spiritual trials are rewarded with divine abundance in the afterlife. | Cf. Ramban's commentary on the World to Come — The author cites Nachmanides' views to validate his mystical framework about the afterlife, particularly noting the paradoxical state of having both body and soul but not requiring physical sustenance.

to Come.[1]

אתה ה׳ עזרתני ונחמתני.[iv] רבון
כל העולמים אתה הוא בטחוני
ואתה הוא פטרוני[i] יהיו נא
אמרי פי לפניך לרצון[ii] שיעשו
לדורות ויחקקו לדורות[iii] ויהיו
קורין בהם והוגין בהם ונוטלין
שכר עליהם ואגורה באהלך
עולמים[iv] ופי ידבר חכמות ועיני
יאירו במאור תורה ורגלי ירוצו
לשמוע דברי עתיק יומיא[v] אמן
כן יהי רצון:[vi]

You, O LORD, have helped me and comforted me.[2] Master of all worlds, You are my trust and You are my protector. May the words of my mouth be acceptable before You,[1] that they may endure for generations and be engraved for generations, and that people may read them and meditate on them and receive reward for them.[2] And may I dwell in Your tent forever, and may my mouth speak wisdom, and may my eyes be illuminated with the light of Torah, and may my feet run to hear the words of the Ancient of Days.[3] Amen, may it be Your will.

פרק מ״ב

Chapter 42

[1]The text distinguishes between two afterlife states: the 'World of Souls' (עולם הנשמות), an intermediate state after death, and the 'World to Come' (עולם הבא), the ultimate state after resurrection. This distinction is important in Jewish eschatology and throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[1]This concluding prayer reveals a deeply personal dimension of Aaron Berechia of Modena's work. Having completed his comprehensive guide to death rituals and afterlife theology, he now expresses both gratitude for divine assistance and his hope that his writing will have lasting impact.

[2]The author consciously frames his scholarly work as a form of divine service, seeking God's approval for his efforts to systematize Jewish approaches to death and dying.

[3]This reflects a central theme in Ma'avar Yabok that proper ritual practices create spiritual merit not only for the deceased but also for those who perform them. Here the author extends this principle to those who will study his book.

[4]By concluding with this kabbalistic reference to the highest aspect of divinity, the author reinforces the mystical framework that has structured his entire approach to death and the afterlife throughout Ma'avar Yabok.

[iv]This opening line quotes Psalm 86:17, expressing gratitude for divine assistance and comfort.

[i]The term 'patron' (פטרוני) borrows from Roman legal terminology, referring to God as both the author's source of trust and legal advocate/protector.

[ii]This phrase echoes the conclusion of the Amidah prayer (Psalm 19:15), but here applies specifically to the author's written work rather than personal prayer.

[iii]The verb 'yechakeku' (engraved) suggests permanence, possibly alluding to the printing of his book.

[iv]Echoes Psalm 61:5, expressing the author's hope for spiritual immortality through his written work.

[v]This Aramaic term 'Ancient of Days' appears in Daniel 7:9 and is also a kabbalistic reference to the highest aspect of divinity (Atik Yomin).

[vi]Cf. Psalm 86:17 — By beginning with this biblical verse of divine comfort, the author frames the entire work of Ma'avar Yabok as divinely assisted, suggesting that proper death rituals similarly provide divine comfort to the deceased. | Cf. Psalm 19:15 — By adapting this familiar liturgical formula to his written work, the author presents Ma'avar Yabok as a form of prayer and divine service rather than merely an academic treatise. | Cf. Psalm 61:5 — The author hopes his book will grant him a form of spiritual immortality, consistent with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on proper religious practices ensuring positive afterlife experiences. | Cf. Daniel 7:9 — This reference connects the conclusion to Ma'avar Yabok's frequent discussions of divine judgment after death, while also introducing the kabbalistic dimension where 'Atik Yomin' represents the highest aspect of divinity.

נפש ברכה תדושן[vii] אשר מפרי
אמרי פיך אשבע טיב מאתך
תהלתי המעיין וקורא באהבה
בחמשה אמרותי אלה[viii] הגם
דלכאורה האי דישנא אינו כדאי
להאי פרדשנא כמוך אחת אשאל
מעמך אותה אבקש כי אל נא
תזלזל בפרורין אלה דאפילו
בעלי חיים לעולם אין נדחין כ״ש
פרורי תורה[i] כי רמז פרורין
לפי הנדרש ממחצדי חקלא
עילאה[ii] הם סוד פרפראות
התורה וכמו דשרא דעניותא
רדיף אבתריה דמאן דמזלזל
בפירורין דנחמא כדאמרי׳
בגמרין ובזהר פ׳ פנחס ובפ׳
עקב בן עניותא דדעתא אזיל
ח״ו בתר מאן דמזלזל בפירורי
התורה הנה רובם של פרקי
מאמרות אלו בכלם אם ראשון
ראשון יתקיים בידך ועוד
יהיה נא פי שנים ברוחך אליו

A generous soul will be enriched,[A] and from the fruit of your lips I will be satisfied with goodness. My praise comes from you, reader who studies with love these five discourses of mine.[4] Although at first glance this humble offering may not seem worthy of 5R
such a distinguished interpreter as yourself,[A] I ask one thing of you, this I request: please do not belittle these crumbs, for even animals are never rejected, how much more so crumbs of Torah.[1] For these crumbs, according to what is taught by the "reapers 10R
of the supernal field,"[2] contain the secret of the side dishes of Torah. And just as poverty pursues one who belittles bread crumbs, as stated in the Talmud and in the Zohar in Parashat Pinchas and Parashat Ekev, similarly, poverty of knowledge—God forbid— 15R
follows one who belittles crumbs of Torah.

Behold, if you retain most of these chapters and discourses, one after another, and furthermore, may you have a double portion of their spirit,[B] then with your understanding you will grow stronger in each of 20R
them with superior wisdom. Perhaps you will say, "I want both his sweetness and his terrors."[3] This

[A] Or: "A blessing-giving soul will be made fat" — This more literal translation preserves the physicality of the Hebrew verb 'תדושן' (will be made fat/prosperous) and maintains the biblical idiom. However, the idiomatic translation I chose better conveys the meaning in contemporary English.

[A] Or: "Although at first glance this threshing is not worthy of such an expounder as yourself" — This alternate preserves the wordplay in the original between 'דישנא' (threshing/offering) and 'פרדשנא' (expounder/interpreter). However, the more interpretive translation I chose better conveys the author's intended meaning of humility.

[B] Or: "and moreover, may there be a double portion of their spirit in you" — This alternative more directly translates the construction 'יהיה נא פי שנים ברוחך' but the chosen translation better captures the biblical allusion to Elisha's request to Elijah (2 Kings 2:9).

[1] The author explicitly refers to his work as comprising five major sections or discourses, confirming the overall structure of Ma'avar Yabok.

[2] The metaphor of 'crumbs' appears throughout this passage, with the author humbly describing his insights as mere crumbs while simultaneously arguing for their value, drawing on the rabbinic concept that even seemingly minor elements of Torah study have profound significance.

[3] This poetic kabbalistic phrase refers to mystics who harvest divine wisdom from higher spiritual realms. The author is positioning his work within this mystical tradition.

[4] The author acknowledges that his work contains both pleasant and challenging aspects, likely referring to the comforting elements of his death rituals alongside the fearsome descriptions of judgment and afterlife.

[vii] The author begins with a creative adaptation of Proverbs 11:25, "A generous person will be enriched," applying it to the relationship between the author and reader.

[i] The author refers to his work as 'five discourses,' confirming the five-part structure of Ma'avar Yabok.

[ii] The metaphor of 'crumbs of Torah' reflects the author's humility while simultaneously arguing for the value of seemingly minor insights, a common rhetorical device in rabbinic literature.

[iii] This poetic phrase 'reapers of the supernal field' is a kabbalistic term from the Zohar referring to mystics who harvest divine wisdom from higher realms.

אז בתבונתך חילים תגבר בכל אחד מהם ביתרון הכשר חכמה[iii] ואולי תאמר איהו בעינא ובסימותיה עם ביעתותיה בעינא. יען כי הרבה הקדמות וחדושים ודרושים כוללים הנוגעים לענין מעשה ביילתי בהם באגב וקני. ובשפה ברורה התהלכתי בהם ברחבה ובדרך קצרה וישיחו אמונ״ה יגידו צד״ק דצבורים בעינן להו ופרשת נא כנפיך על עבדך כי גואל אתה.[i] וזאת התעודה בישראל לקיים כל דבר תורה ולקבלו באהבה רבה ואפילו מקטלי קני באגמא[ii]

is because I have incorporated many foundational principles, innovations, and comprehensive expositions relevant to practical matters as incidental inclusions. I have discussed them in clear language, both expansively and concisely, so they speak of faith and declare righteousness, for we need them collected together. Now spread your wings over your servant, for you are a redeemer. And this is the testimony in Israel: to uphold every word of Torah and receive it with great love, even from those who cut reeds in the swamp.[A]

ובזה מתרחב תקון הקדושה העליונה ויהדר סודרא למרי דעלמא עם כמה ככרים דנרד כנדרש בזהר פ׳ חקת בסוד החליצה[iii] על מנהג קנין סודר שהוא רמז לבל יגלה האדם כנף

Through this, the rectification of the supernal holiness expands, and the cloth is returned to the Master of the Universe[B] with many measures of spikenard,[1] as expounded in the Zohar portion of Chukat regarding the ritual of chalitzah. This reflects the custom of kinyan sudar[2] (acquisition

[A] Or: "from reed-cutters in the marsh" — This alternative is more concise but loses some of the vivid imagery. The Talmudic idiom refers to people of seemingly low status or simple laborers, which the author uses as a self-deprecating reference.

[B] Or: "and the scarf is adorned for the Master of the World" — The term 'סודרא' (sudra) can be translated as cloth, scarf, or garment used in symbolic transactions. The verb 'יהדר' can mean either 'return' or 'adorn/beautify.' This alternate translation emphasizes the ceremonial beautification aspect rather than the return aspect.

[1] The Hebrew 'ככרים דנרד' refers to 'kikkarim' (measures or talents, a unit of weight) of 'nard' (spikenard, an aromatic oil). This imagery evokes the precious offerings made in Temple times and is being used metaphorically for spiritual offerings or rectifications.

[2] Kinyan sudar is a formal act of acquisition in Jewish law where one party hands over a garment (typically a handkerchief or scarf) to another to symbolically confirm a transaction. The author is interpreting this legal formality as containing profound mystical significance.

[iv] This phrase alludes to Ecclesiastes 2:13, "Then I saw that wisdom excels folly as light excels darkness," suggesting that proper understanding of the text will illuminate the reader's mind.

[i] This is an allusion to Ruth 3:9, where Ruth asks Boaz to spread his garment over her as her redeemer. Here the author is asking the reader to take his work under their protection.

[ii] Cf. Proverbs 11:25 — The author uses this verse to suggest that readers who generously engage with his text will be spiritually enriched by it | Cf. Zohar, Parashat Pinchas — The author draws a parallel between physical and spiritual poverty, suggesting that just as wasting bread crumbs leads to material poverty, dismissing small insights from Torah leads to spiritual poverty | Cf. 2 Kings 2:9 — This alludes to Elisha asking Elijah for a double portion of his spirit, suggesting the author hopes readers will receive abundant spiritual insight from his work, even exceeding what he himself possessed | Cf. Ruth 3:9 — The author is humbly asking the reader to take his work under their protection and care, just as Boaz was asked to be Ruth's protector and redeemer

[iii] This refers to the biblical ritual called 'chalitzah' described in Deuteronomy 25:5-10, where a brother-in-law who refuses to marry his deceased brother's widow removes his shoe as part of a ceremony. In kabbalistic interpretation, this ritual contains deep significance regarding the soul's garments and cosmic rectification.

אביו[iv] שהם הקליפות הנקראים
ערוה ואסור לגלותם ולהמשיכם
אל גבול הקדושה ברם צריך
לכסותם בכנף מלבושו שהוא
רמז לתקונים שתעשה הנשמה
בלבוש החומרי הזה ולזה נתקן
קנין סודר לקיים כל דבר כמו
שאין השגה לנשמה רק בסוד
הלבושים כאשר הרחבנו במאמר
ראשון ושני. וכן המקנה דבר
לחברו אם לא יקיים הדבר
ההוא שקנה בקנין סודר אפילו
לא תקע כפו לחבירו אז הוא
באילו פגע ח״ו למעלה וכסות
שהיה מכוסה נגלה על ידו אם
כן בעת ששולף אפי׳ איש אנוש
את נעלו[i] שהוא בחינת נשמתו
הגם שתהיה מאיפה התחתונה
שלאדם הראשון ומדיוטא זעירא
מבחינת נעל ונתן לרעהו לאכול
מפריה זאת לפנים בישראל
לשמור דברי תורה בתוך לבבם
ובאהבתה ישגו תמיד ואורח
חיים בל יפלסון כל עוד אשר
נוכח עיני ה׳ דרכי איש כי בכל
אשר נעשה תחת השמים להשלים
נו״ת צד״ק[ii] יש חפץ למעלה
והכל לפי הכוונה. הנה זה חזיתי
ואספרה ריש מלין לבד בהנהגת
המלמדי תנוקות אשר הפליגו

through a garment), which symbolizes that one should not uncover his father's corner, representing the kelipot (negative forces) that are called "nakedness." It is forbidden to reveal them or draw them into the realm of holiness. Rather, one must cover them with the corner of one's garment, symbolizing the rectifications that the soul performs within this physical garment. For this reason, the kinyan sudar was established to confirm every matter, just as the soul can only be apprehended through the mystery of garments, as we have explained at length in the first and second discourses. 40R 45R 50R

Similarly, when one transfers something to another through a kinyan sudar and does not fulfill what was acquired through this symbolic act—even if he did not clasp hands with his fellow—it is as if he has, heaven forbid, damaged the supernal realms, and what was covered has been revealed through him. Therefore, when even an ordinary person removes his shoe—which represents his soul, even if it comes from the lowest level of Adam and from the smallest dimension of the aspect of "shoe"—and gives it to his fellow to partake of its fruit, this was formerly practiced in Israel to preserve the words of Torah within their hearts.[1] In their love for Torah they would always be enraptured, and they would not deviate from the path of life so long as "the ways of man are before the eyes of the Lord," for in everything done under the heavens to perfect Tzedek (Righteousness)[A] there is divine purpose, and all de- 55R 60R 65R

[A] Or: "to complete the letters Nun-Vav-Tav of TzeDeK" — The original text uses the abbreviation 'נו״ת' which likely refers to the letters nun, vav, and tav in the word צדק (tzedek). This alternate translation makes the kabbalistic letter-based interpretation more explicit.

[1] The passage transitions from discussing ritual symbolism to how these principles apply to the transmission of Torah, particularly in education. The author suggests that proper understanding of symbolic acts creates proper intention in Torah study and observance.

[iv] This is an allusion to Deuteronomy 23:1, 'A man shall not take his father's wife, nor uncover his father's skirt/corner.' In kabbalistic interpretation, the 'corner' or 'wing' (kanaf) refers to spiritual dimensions that should remain properly covered.

[i] In kabbalistic symbolism, the shoe represents the lowest aspect of the soul that interfaces with the physical world, just as a shoe connects the body to the ground. The removal of a shoe in ritual contexts represents a transition between spiritual states or realms.

[ii] This is a kabbalistic reference to completing or perfecting the divine attribute of Tzedek (Righteousness). The letters nun-vav-tav (נו״ת) are the latter part of the word Tzedek (צד״ק), and may relate to mystical letter combinations or gematria.

שכרם בבתרא[iii] [iv]

pends on one's intention.[2] 70R

Behold, this I have seen and will relate, just the beginning of the matter, regarding the conduct of teachers of children, whose reward was described so extensively in Bava Batra.[1]

בפירוש פסוק והמשכילים יזהירו כזוהר הרקיע[i] וכו׳. הנה בעת אשר האדם מטפל ללמד נערי בני ישראל קריאת התורה שבכתב ופסוק טעמים אז נשמתו נעשית מרכבה להנהגת עשייה רוחניות ויאדיר מאד כח הבנתם אם יכוין לתקון ושעשע יונק על חור פתן ועל מאורת צפעוני ותקון מדור האופנים עולם העשיה הנהגת סנדלפון ובזה ומלכותו בכל משלה לאבנעא לאינון קליפין

On the interpretation of the verse "And those who are wise shall shine like the brightness of the firmament" (Daniel 12:3): When a person endeavors to teach the young children of Israel to read the Written Torah and learn the cantillation marks, his soul becomes a vehicle for the governance of the spiritual realm of Asiyah[2] (Action). He greatly strengthens their understanding if he intends to bring rectification and to "delight the nursling over the hole of the asp and over the den of the viper" (based on Isaiah 11:8). He rectifies the dwelling place of the Ophanim (angelic Wheels) in the world of Asiyah under the governance of Sandalphon. Through this, "His king- 75R 80R 85R

[2]The concept that 'all depends on intention' (hakol lefi hakavanah) is a fundamental kabbalistic principle suggesting that the spiritual efficacy of an action is determined by the consciousness and intention behind it, not merely its external performance.

[1]The passage ends by beginning to transition to a discussion of teachers of children, referring to Talmudic teachings about their great reward. This suggests the author is about to explain how teaching Torah corresponds to different cosmic levels, particularly how teaching children relates to the World of Action (Asiyah).

[2]The Hebrew term 'מרכבה' (vehicle/chariot) has profound mystical significance in Kabbalah, referring to humans serving as conduits for divine influence based on Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot. The author uses this term to suggest that teaching creates a cosmic connection between worlds.

[iii]This refers to the Talmudic tractate Bava Batra, which contains a discussion about the great spiritual reward reserved for those who teach Torah to children. This reference begins a transition to a new topic about the spiritual dimensions of Torah teaching.

[iv]Cf. Zohar, Parashat Chukat — The author explicitly references the Zohar commentary on Parashat Chukat regarding the chalitzah ritual. This reference reinforces the kabbalistic understanding of the ritual of removing a shoe as having cosmic significance in terms of spiritual rectification. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, First and Second Discourses — The author directly references his own earlier writings in the first and second discourses of Ma'avar Yabok, where he apparently discussed the concept of spiritual garments or vestments of the soul at length. This self-reference demonstrates how the author is building a cohesive theological framework across the entire work. | Cf. Ruth 4:7 — The passage alludes to the biblical custom described in Ruth 4:7 regarding the removal of a shoe to confirm transactions. The author is drawing a parallel between this ancient practice and kabbalistic concepts of soul rectification, suggesting that mundane legal practices had deeper spiritual significance. | Cf. Deuteronomy 25:5-10 — The reference to the chalitzah ritual comes from the biblical commandment in Deuteronomy 25:5-10, where a brother-in-law who refuses to marry his deceased brother's widow removes his shoe as part of a public ceremony. The author is interpreting this ritual in kabbalistic terms, seeing the physical shoe as representing spiritual dimensions of the soul. | Cf. Talmud Bavli, Bava Batra — The final line refers to the extensive discussion in the Talmudic tractate Bava Batra regarding the great spiritual reward granted to those who teach Torah to children. The author seems to be transitioning to a new topic about spiritual levels of Torah teaching, which corresponds to different cosmic realms.

[i]This phrase from Daniel 12:3 is traditionally interpreted as referring to teachers of Torah, particularly those who guide others in spiritual knowledge. It serves as the foundation for the author's hierarchy of teaching levels.

אשר יצאו מבן הגר המצרית
שהם לקדר ולמשמע ולדומא
ולמשא[ii] על התנוק הבורח
תמיד מבית הספר ומשם יעלה
בהדרגה לסדר המשנה עם
הגדולים מהם ואז ישים אל לבו
להעשות מרכבה לסדר הנהגת
עולם היצירה מסכן הנער דז׳
עולמת שפרתי דאינון נערות
ותמן אית סוד עץ הדעת טוב ורע
טהור וטמא איסור והיתר מותר
ואסור ובזה נהרא מכפיה מבריך
כי עמודא דאמצעיתא תקנן
ביצירה בסוד תורת עץ חיים.
וכשמורה הוראות ומפלפל
וממית עצמו על דברי תורה
בכח עיונו עד כי יוציא דין או
דבר ברור לאמתו. וכן בעת
שמלמד תורה לתלמידים חברים
הוא מקביל להנהגת עולם הכסא
וחביט חביט עליה ובריך בסוד
זיעת החיות הנושאות הכסא כי
בחסד של תורה יכין כסא וכל
עמודוהי וסמכוהי ובתבו״נה
יתכונן שכן אימא עילאה מקננא
בכורסיא[i] ובהכות בשבט מוסר
לתלמידיו יכוין לסוד ערקתא
דמסאנא[ii] כי בעת ששלף איש

ship rules over all" (Psalms 103:19), subduing those husks (negative forces) that emanated from the son of Hagar the Egyptian[3]—namely Kedar, Mishma, Dumah, and Massa (descendants of Ishmael)—who burden the child who constantly flees from school. 90R

From there, one ascends gradually to teaching Mishnah to older students. At this stage, one should set his heart on becoming a vehicle for the governance of the World of Yetzirah (Formation), as in "the youth is endangered" (based on Ecclesiastes 4:13) through the seven handmaidens who are young wome[A]n. There exists the secret of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, pure and impure, permitted and forbidden. Through this, "light shines from his palms" (Habakkuk 3:4), for the central column is established in Yetzirah through the secret of the Torah of the Tree of Life.[1] 95R 100R

When one renders halakhic decisions, engages in dialectical analysis, and sacrifices himself for the words of Torah through the power of his intellect until he produces a clear ruling or matter of truth—and likewise when he teaches Torah to colleagues and students—he corresponds to the governance of the World of the Throne (Beriah). He toils intensely and receives blessing through the secret of the "sweat of the living creatures that bear the Throne," for through the loving-kindness of Torah, "he establishes the throne and all its 105R 110R 115R

[A] Or: "the youthful soul traverses the seven cosmic maidens" — This highly mystical phrase is difficult to translate precisely. My alternative suggests a more cosmological interpretation where the 'נער' (youth) represents the soul journeying through spiritual realms represented by the seven maidens, rather than being in danger from them. However, this is a speculative interpretation of an obscure kabbalistic concept.

[3] The author draws on kabbalistic cosmology where 'קליפות' (husks/shells) represent negative spiritual forces that obstruct divine light. By associating these forces with Ishmael (son of Hagar), the author creatively interprets biblical genealogy as a spiritual metaphor for obstacles in Torah education.

[1] This reflects the kabbalistic concept that Torah study, particularly of Jewish law, establishes cosmic balance by strengthening the 'central column' (primarily the sefirah of Tiferet) in the spiritual world of Yetzirah, creating harmony between the right side (mercy) and left side (judgment).

[ii] These are names of Ishmael's sons mentioned in Genesis 25:13-14. The author creatively interprets them as representing negative spiritual forces that burden children's learning, drawing on the rabbinic tradition that viewed Ishmael negatively.

[i] This phrase draws on the Zoharic teaching that Binah (the Supernal Mother) 'nests' in the world of Beriah (the Throne). It refers to a foundational kabbalistic concept of how divine emanations manifest in different spiritual worlds.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase literally means 'strap of the sandal' and refers to the biblical ritual of chalitzah (Deuteronomy 25:9-10) where a widow removes the shoe of her husband's brother if he refuses to marry her. In Kabbalah, this ritual became a metaphor for transfers of spiritual power and obligation.

נעלו ונותן לרעהו זאת התעודה
תתקיים בישראל ודי לאוזן
שומעת וכוונתו תהיה לבטל
הקליפות אשר הם בהדרגה
120 בג׳ עולמות הנזכרים שהם
קדר ואדבאל ומבשם או לוטן
ושובל וצבעון וענה[iii] ומפרי
פיו ישבע איש כזה כי יזכה
להעמיד תלמידים הגונים ובעת
125 שלאם מלאם יאמץ ויהיו שדיו
באשכלות הגפן להרביץ תורה
לשמה ברבים אם יזכה לדחות
מעליו גאה וגאון ודרך רע ופי
תהפוכו״ת אשר מאד שנאתי או
130 בעת שעוסק במעשה מרכבה
ולבו דואג בקרבו אם תלמיד
חכם ומבין מדעתו ומוסר לו
ראשי פרקי הקדושה והיחוד אז
חיילים יגבר והוא כלי מחזיק
135 ברכה מהנהגת עולם האצילות
וימצא בשינון ההוא מאה
שערים[i] ויברכהו ה׳ וילך הלוך
וגדל וגם ברוך יהיה והצעת
דרוש זה עם תאיו ואולמיו בלי
140 נדר יבא במקום כבודו אשר
יעדתיו שם אם יגזור ה׳ לבד פי

pillars and supports." "Through Understanding it is established" (Proverbs 24:3), for the Supernal Mother (Binah) nests in the Throne.

When disciplining his students with the rod of instruction, he should contemplate the secret of the "strap of the sandal,"[B][2] for when a man removes his shoe and gives it to his fellow, this testimony is established in Israel. This is sufficient for the attentive ear. His intention should be to nullify the husks that exist in hierarchical order in the three worlds mentioned—namely Kedar, Adba'el, and Mibsam, or Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, and Anah (biblical names representing negative forces).

From the fruit of his lips shall such a person be satisfied, for he will merit raising worthy students. When he wearies himself completely, he will be strengthened, and "his breasts will be like clusters of the vine"[A] (Song of Songs 7:8) to spread Torah for its own sake among the many—if he merits to cast off pride, arrogance, evil ways, and "the mouth of perversity, which I greatly hate"[1] (Proverbs 8:13).

Or when he engages in the Work of the Chariot (mystical studies),[2] with his heart anxious within him, if he is a Torah scholar who understands through his own intellect, and transmits to him the introductory chapters of holiness and unification,

[B] Or: "shoelace ritual" — The phrase 'ערקתא דסאנא' refers to the ritual of chalitzah (shoe removal) mentioned in Deuteronomy 25:9-10. While 'strap of the sandal' is literally correct, 'shoelace ritual' might better convey the ceremonial significance to readers unfamiliar with this Jewish legal concept of transferring rights or obligations.

[A] Or: "his teachings will be like clusters of the vine" — While the literal translation refers to 'breasts' (שדיו), in this context it likely metaphorically refers to the teacher's nourishing teachings that sustain students spiritually, similar to how a vine's clusters provide sustenance. A more contextually appropriate translation might use 'teachings' rather than the anatomical 'breasts.'

[2] The author makes a surprising connection between pedagogical discipline and the ritual of chalitzah (shoe removal), suggesting that both involve a formal transfer of responsibility. This reflects the kabbalistic tendency to find mystical correspondences between seemingly unrelated religious practices.

[1] The author emphasizes that spiritual advancement through teaching requires moral refinement. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that cosmic rectification (tikkun) requires both ritual action and ethical improvement.

[2] Ma'aseh Merkavah (Work of the Chariot) is a technical term for the most esoteric aspects of Jewish mysticism, based on Ezekiel's vision. The author places this as the highest level of teaching, corresponding to the world of Atzilut, indicating that mystical instruction is considered the pinnacle of Torah teaching.

[i] These names appear in Genesis 36 as descendants of Esau and Seir the Horite. In kabbalistic literature, they represent negative spiritual forces (kelipot) that must be subdued through Torah study and mitzvot.

[ii] This is an allusion to Genesis 26:12, where Isaac sowed and reaped a hundredfold. In rabbinic literature, this became a metaphor for exceptional spiritual or intellectual achievement, particularly in Torah study.

פתחתי בו כאן להודיע כי התורה חסד על לשונה ובכפה פרשה לעני וידיה שלחה לאביון כמוני היום אשר מפרי כפיה נטעתי ושתלתי חמשה חלוקים אלו מן שלולית קטנה שלה. והיא תקדמך ברכות לעד. ואורח צדיקים ומשכילי עם הנבונים הוא כאור נוגה הולך ואור עד נכון היום כי מלך אל יקום עמו. [ii]

then he will gain strength upon strength. He becomes a vessel holding blessing from the governance of the World of Atzilut (Emanation), and in that study he will find "a hundredfold" (Genesis 26:12). 145R
The Lord will bless him, and "he will go on, growing ever greater" (Genesis 26:13), and he shall also be blessed.

The exposition of this discourse with its chambers and halls will, without a vow, come in its place 150R
of honor where I have designated it, if the Lord so decrees. I have only introduced it here to make known that "the Torah has kindness on her tongue, she opens her palm to the poor, and stretches out her hands to the needy" (based on Proverbs 31:26, 20) 155R
like myself today, who from the fruit of her palms have planted and sown these five divisions from her small puddle. And she shall greet you with blessings forever. "The path of the righteous" and the wise and understanding people "is like the light of dawn, 160R
growing brighter until the full day" (Proverbs 4:18), for God the King will arise with His people.

ואז תמלא הארץ דעה את ה׳ כמים לים מכסים [i] ועצת ה׳ לעולם תעמוד ובחכמה יבנה בית עילאה ובתבונה יתכונן כי

And then "the earth shall be full of the knowledge of the Lord, as the waters cover the sea" and the counsel of the Lord shall stand forever, and through wisdom 165R
the supernal house[A] shall be built,[1] and through

[A] Or: "celestial dwelling" — While 'supernal house' is the most direct translation capturing the kabbalistic meaning, 'celestial dwelling' might better convey the concept of a divine spiritual structure to readers unfamiliar with kabbalistic terminology.

[1] The term 'בית עילאה' (supernal house) has kabbalistic significance, referring to the divine spiritual

[iii] Cf. Daniel 12:3 — The author uses this verse to establish a hierarchy of Torah teachers, suggesting that different levels of teaching correspond to different spiritual worlds in the kabbalistic cosmology (Asiyah, Yetzirah, Beriah, and Atzilut). The 'shining' represents the spiritual illumination achieved through teaching at progressively higher levels. | Cf. Isaiah 11:8 — In Ma'avar Yabok, this image is repurposed as a metaphor for how teaching Torah to children transforms dangerous spiritual forces (represented by venomous creatures) into harmless ones. It suggests that proper education creates spiritual protection for vulnerable young souls. | Cf. Ma'avar Yabok, Ma'amar 1 — This passage extends that framework specifically to Torah teaching, showing how different levels of teaching correspond to and activate different spiritual worlds. It follows the same pattern of explaining how physical actions below create metaphysical effects above that is central to Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death rituals. | Cf. Ezekiel's Vision of the Divine Chariot (Ezekiel 1) — The author draws a parallel between the intense intellectual effort of Torah study and the celestial creatures' labor in bearing the divine throne. The 'sweat' of these creatures becomes a metaphor for the effort of deep Torah study, suggesting that such study actually strengthens the cosmic throne structure. | Cf. Zohar, Section on Yitro — This passage in Ma'avar Yabok applies the Zoharic cosmology specifically to Torah teaching, showing how teaching at different levels corresponds to different divine configurations. The reference to 'Supernal Mother' (Binah) nesting in the Throne (Beriah) follows standard kabbalistic correspondence.

[i] This phrase is quoted from Isaiah 11:9, which describes the messianic era when divine knowledge will permeate all existence. The author uses this to express hope for the ultimate spiritual enlightenment that will come when all ritual work described in the book is properly performed.

איש דעת מאמץ כח ויגדל נא כח אדנ״י ויהי שמיה רבא מברך לעלם ולעלמי עלמיא[ii] אמן כן יהי רצון. יהי כבוד ה׳ לעולם ישמח ה׳ במעשיו:[i]

understanding it shall be established, for a man of knowledge increases strength.[B] May the power of the Lord be magnified, and may His great Name be blessed forever and ever,[2] Amen, so may it be His will. May the glory of the Lord endure forever; may the Lord rejoice in His works.

[B] Or: "one who possesses knowledge strengthens power" — This alternative translation emphasizes the active role of the knowledgeable person in strengthening divine power, which aligns with Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on human ritual actions affecting divine realms.

structure that is established through proper observance of rituals and commandments. In the context of Ma'avar Yabok, this likely refers to the cosmic spiritual architecture that proper death rituals help to maintain and perfect.

[1] This is a translation of the Aramaic phrase from the Kaddish prayer, traditionally recited by mourners. Its inclusion at the conclusion of this work on death rituals creates a powerful thematic resonance, as the author ends with the very prayer that mourners would recite following the practices outlined in the book.

[ii] This Aramaic phrase comes from the Kaddish prayer, traditionally recited by mourners. Its inclusion here creates a thematic connection between the conclusion of this book on death rituals and the very prayers it instructs readers to recite.

[i] Cf. Isaiah 11:9 — The author uses this prophetic verse about universal divine knowledge to express hope for the ultimate spiritual enlightenment that will come when all spiritual work is completed. | Cf. Psalm 33:11 — The reference to God's counsel standing forever emphasizes the eternal nature of divine wisdom, contrasting with the temporary nature of human existence discussed throughout Ma'avar Yabok. | Cf. Proverbs 24:3-4 — The author applies this verse about building a house through wisdom to the 'supernal house' (spiritual realm), suggesting that divine wisdom establishes cosmic spiritual structures. | Cf. Proverbs 24:5 — The author uses this wisdom verse to emphasize that true knowledge increases spiritual power, connecting to Ma'avar Yabok's theme of proper knowledge preparing the soul for its journey. | Cf. Kaddish Prayer — The author incorporates language from the Kaddish, a prayer recited by mourners, appropriately concluding this work on death rituals with this liturgical element focused on divine glorification. | Cf. Psalm 104:31 — This final verse expresses hope that God will rejoice in His creation, including the spiritual work accomplished through proper death rituals as outlined in Ma'avar Yabok.

Discourse 10

חתימת הספר / Sealing of the Book

אשריך העולם שהקב״ה מלך בך. ויאמר נא אהרן כי לעולם חסדו ויברך יה מעתה ועד עולם כי מאוצר של חנם חנן אותי במצוה קבועה לדורות על דרך שאמרו בויקרא רבה פ׳ כ״ב שכל מי שהומה ומהמה אחר המצות ומצוה קבועה לדורות אין לו מה הנאה יש לו וחדאי נפשאי ובדיחנא דעתאי כי גם שמעפר יצפצפו אמרותי אלה מהם ילמדו לקח השמחים אלי גיל נשמתם וישישו כי ימצאו קבר כי בזה הנערה בת מלך רו״ח נדיב״ה תבא אל המלך מקץ היות לה כדת הנשים ששה חדשים בשמן המר וששה חדשים בבשמים ובתמרוקי הנשים.[i] כאשר

Fortunate are you, O world, that the Holy One, blessed be He, reigns over you.[1] May Aaron now say, "For His kindness endures forever," and may he bless the Lord from now until eternity, for from His treasury of grace He has favored me with an 5R
enduring commandment for generations, as they said in Leviticus Rabbah, chapter 22: "Whoever yearns and longs after the commandments[A] and an enduring commandment for generations—what pleasure does he have? My soul rejoices and my 10R
mind is gladdened,[B] for even though these sayings of mine chirp from the dust,[2] from them those who rejoice will learn a lesson, their souls will exult, and they will delight when they find a grave.[3] For in this way the maiden, the king's daughter with a noble 15R
spirit, will come to the king after she has fulfilled the women's customary period of six months with bitter oil and six months with spices and women's

[A] Or: "whoever murmurs and yearns for the commandments" — The Hebrew root המה can refer to murmuring or making a sound, which might better capture the audible nature of devotional longing implied in the original text.

[B] Or: "My soul rejoices and my spirit is cheered" — The Aramaic term 'דעתאי' could be rendered as 'spirit' rather than 'mind' to better capture the emotional rather than purely intellectual nature of the gladness described.

[1] The author begins with a traditional formula of praise, but makes it personal by using his own name (Aaron) in the following line.

[2] A humble metaphor comparing his words to the faint chirping of birds in dust, suggesting his awareness of his own mortality and the humble nature of his contribution.

[3] This paradoxical phrase reflects the book's central theme that proper understanding of death is actually a source of spiritual joy rather than sorrow, as it represents the soul's liberation.

[i] This alludes to Esther 2:12, which describes the preparation of young women before meeting King

מאופל ומחשך עיני עורים
תראינה[i] בפרקי גיהנם אשר
סדרנו בשפתי רננות שלנו.
ומלבד אשר דברנו שם בואו
וקחו לכם דוגמא מזה בדברי
החכם בעל העקידה[ii] בשער
כ״ב וכ״ה וס״ט והבורר יברר
לעצמו כי דרך אחרת היא אתו
בהא נסלק ונחית כי ימי״ם תהיה
גאולת הנשמה[iii] ואחר שנה זו
תובל שי לה׳ צבאות עד כי תשוב
אל אחוזתו וכל פקודת גומלי
חסדים אשר יפקדו בגוף יועילו
ויצילו עליו ויחדו בזה פניו
יחורו וטירחא יתירא טרחינן
ואפילו במקום דפסידא לאוקומי
נפשא דמיתא בבילת׳ עילאה
באשר חדשתי והודעתי בדברי
אלו בשם אל אורי וישעי אשר
לא יבושו קויו. ואין הקב״ה
פוסל לשום בריה אלא לכל
הוא מקבל כדאמרי׳ בשמות
רבה פ׳ י״ז שעל ידי אזוב שהוא
שפל שבאילנות גאל את ישראל.
כען אנא משבח ומרומם ומהדר
ובהלליה ובהלל אודה אברם
השם הנכבד והנורא אשר לא
עזב חסדו ואמתו מעם עבד
אדוני זה אפר בעפר יסודו ולא
כראות אנוש יראה ועם כל זה
יותר ממה שהבטחתי אמרתי
לפניכם בהקדמה בכפלים
לתושיה מצאתי כתוב וסדור

cosmetics. Just as from darkness and gloom the
eyes of the blind will see in the chapters on Gehenna 20R
that we arranged in our ‘Lips of Praise.’[1]

And beyond what we spoke of there, come and
take for yourselves an example of this from the words
of the sage, the author of the Akedah, in gates 22, 25,
and 69. One who chooses will clarify for himself, for 25R
he has a different approach to this matter—we shall
ascend and descend with it. For after a time will
come the redemption of the soul, and after that year
it will be brought as a gift to the Lord of Hosts until
it returns to its inheritance. And all the duties of 30R
those who perform acts of kindness that are assigned
to the body will benefit and protect it, and together
in this “his face will turn pale.” We have made ex-
traordinary efforts, even in cases of loss, to establish
the soul of the deceased in the supernal canopy,[2] as 35R
I have innovated and made known in these words of
mine in the name of God, my light and my salvation,
in whom those who hope will not be ashamed.

The Holy One, blessed be He, does not disqualify
any creature; rather, He receives all, as they said in 40R
Exodus Rabbah, chapter 17, that through the hys-
sop, which is the lowliest of plants, He redeemed Is-
rael. Now I praise, exalt, and glorify, and with songs
of praise I acknowledge and bless the honored and
awesome Name, who has not withdrawn His kindness 45R
and truth from this servant of my Lord, who is dust
founded in ashes. He does not see as mortals see,
and despite this, I have found written and arranged
before me in various homiletical teachings more than
what I promised you in the introduction—double the 50R
wisdom[A]—these words clothed on my tongue, and

[A] Or: “with a double measure of sound wisdom” — The term ‘תושיה’ refers specifically to sound, practical wisdom or substance, which might better convey the nature of what the author claims to have provided beyond his initial promise.

[1] The author refers to an earlier section of Ma’avar Yabok titled ‘Siftei Renanot’ (Lips of Praise), which contains discussions of the afterlife including Gehenna (the realm of spiritual purification).
[2] This refers to the mystical concept of the soul finding rest under the ‘divine canopy’ in the Garden of Eden after death, a key goal of the proper rituals described throughout Ma’avar Yabok.

Ahasuerus. Here it serves as an allegory for the soul’s preparation before meeting the divine King after death.

[i] This phrase, drawing on Isaiah 29:18, creates a powerful contrast between spiritual blindness and insight, suggesting that understanding death properly brings illumination rather than darkness.
[ii] This refers to Rabbi Isaac Arama (c. 1420-1494), author of Akedat Yitzchak, a philosophical commentary on the Torah. The author is directing readers to specific sections where Arama discusses relevant concepts about the afterlife.
[iii] The phrase “redemption of the soul” refers to the process by which the soul is liberated from physical constraints after death and ascends to higher spiritual realms.

לפני באגדות דרושים שונים
שמלתם על לשוני ופקודתם
שמרה רומי יען חסד ואמת נפגשו
צדק ושלום נשקו[i] וה׳ יתן חכמה
להולכי תום מלבד שהרבה מהם
השמטתים ובלבי צפנתים כי
להג הרבה יגיעת בשר ויקום
פרחם של מאמרים אלו קדם
עמא פזיזא המאספים אתר מתנה
עם הנקראו על ידי רועה נאמן
ממלכת כהנים וגוי קדוש. ואל
נא יזלזלו במשיחת״א קדישא
דאורייתא דכל פורתא דסובלנו
חזי לברכומא ריסקא מחילא
דאורייתא.[ii] יהא רעוא דאטום
בשיראי דעולמתא שפירתא
דהיא רישא דכולי כרכא ולא
תפסק מצוה זאת מביתי כאשר
הבטיחונו חכמינו ז״ל בשמות
רבה אמר ר״י מכאן אתה למד
מי שמקבל על עצמו לעשות
מצוה אין אותה מצוה פוסקת
מביתו וגם לעתיד לבא אמרו שם
פ׳ כ״א שכל א׳ עומד ומשמיע
למודו וכבי״כול הקב״ה יושב
ומשמיע עמהם כדפ״ב וכל בניך
למודי ה׳ ויקיים בי תפלת נעים
זמירות כדאמרו במדרש פרק
י״ט אמר דוד רבון העולמים
כשאני עוסק בחקיך לא יהא
רשות ליצר הרע להציץ בי
שנאמר הורני ה׳ דרכך אהלך
באמתך שלא יטעה אותי יצר
הרע ואני מתבייש מן הצדיקים

my spirit has preserved their mandate, because kindness and truth have met, righteousness and peace have kissed, and the Lord gives wisdom to those who walk in integrity. Beyond this, I have omitted many of them and kept them hidden in my heart, for excessive talk is weariness of the flesh.

May the blossoms of these statements arise before the hasty nation, the gatherers of gift offerings[A] with those who were called by the faithful shepherd "a kingdom of priests and a holy nation." Please do not disrespect the holy anointing of the Torah, for every bit of understanding is worthy of the crushed saffron from the strength of the Torah. May it be His will that I bind myself with the silks of the beautiful maiden[B] who is the head of the entire city,[1] and may this commandment not cease from my house, as our sages of blessed memory promised us in Exodus Rabbah. Rabbi Yochanan said: "From here you learn that whoever takes upon himself to perform a commandment, that commandment will not cease from his house." And they also said there in chapter 21 that in the future, each one will stand and proclaim his learning, and as it were, the Holy One, blessed be He, will sit and proclaim with them, as it says, "And all your children shall be taught by the Lord."

May He fulfill in me the prayer of the sweet psalmist, as they said in the Midrash, chapter 19: "David said, 'Master of the Universe, when I engage in Your statutes, let not the evil inclination have permission to peer at me,[2] as it is said, "Teach me, O Lord, Your way; I will walk in Your truth," so that the evil inclination will not lead me astray. I am embarrassed before the righteous, for because he leads me astray, I withhold myself from words

[A] Or: "the impetuous people who gather at the place of the gift" — This difficult phrase might refer to the Israelites, often called 'impetuous' in rabbinic literature, and 'אתר מתנה' could be understood as 'the place of the gift' (possibly referring to Mount Sinai or the Temple).

[B] Or: "May it be His will that I wrap myself in the silken garments of the beautiful maiden" — The verb 'אטום' has connotations of wrapping or covering oneself, which might better capture the image of being enveloped in the protection and beauty of Torah wisdom.

[1] This likely refers to the Torah or divine wisdom personified as a female figure, a common metaphor in Jewish mystical literature.

[2] The author quotes King David's prayer from a midrashic source, identifying with the struggle against distractions and intellectual errors that might compromise one's Torah study.

[i] This quotes Psalm 85:11, which describes divine attributes meeting together. The author uses this to suggest that his work similarly brings together different aspects of truth and righteousness.

[ii] This difficult Aramaic phrase suggests that even a small amount of understanding is worthy of being treated as precious as crushed saffron (a valuable spice) due to the power of Torah.

שמתוך שהוא מתעה אותי אני מונע עצמי מדברי תורה ואני בא להשמיע תלמודי לפניך וקטנים ממני הם משיבים ואומרים אינו כך ואני מתבייש. אלא עשה לבי אחד כדי שיהא עסוק בתורה הדא הוא דכתיב יחי לבי תמים בחקיך למען לא אבוש. ע״כ ולא יבצר מלבבי את אשר יזם לעשות בלי נדר ברוב חיל עם המהדורות הראויות ונזכה נחיה ונראה בשובע שמחות ונירש נעימות בימינך נצח ויספיק לנו מעדני גן עדן והמלך שבארץ יברך את המלך שבשמים וכסא כבוד ינחילנו אמן סלה ועד: [i]

of Torah. And when I come to make my learning heard before You, those lesser than I respond and say, "It is not so," and I am embarrassed. Rather, make my heart single-minded so that it may be engaged in Torah.' This is what is written: 'May my heart be perfect in Your statutes so that I will not be ashamed.'"

And He will not withhold from my heart that which He has planned to do, without a vow, with great might and with the appropriate revisions. May we merit to live and see an abundance of joys, and inherit pleasantness at Your right hand forever. May He provide us with the delicacies of the Garden of Eden, and may the king on earth bless the King in heaven, and may He bequeath to us a throne of glory. Amen, Selah, and forever.

בנל״ך ואע״י לק״י [ii]

Blessed is He and blessed is His Name, and may His Will be done.[AB]

[A] Or: "Blessed is His Name and may the Will of the Holy One be fulfilled." — This appears to be a standard closing acronym typical of Jewish religious texts. The letters likely stand for phrases such as 'Baruch Hu' (Blessed is He) and possibly 'L'Kvodo Yitbarach' (For His blessed glory). The alternative offers a slightly different arrangement of blessing elements while maintaining the reverent tone.

[B] Or: "Blessed is His crown, and by His help, may His glory be exalted." — The acronym could potentially represent other formulaic phrases. This interpretation assumes letters might stand for 'Baruch Nizro L'Kvodo' and 'V'Al Ezrato Yitromem Kvodo' or similar phrases, which would create a more poetic closing blessing focusing on divine glory and exaltation.

[i] Cf. Leviticus Rabbah 22 — The author cites this midrash to establish the spiritual value of dedicating oneself to fulfilling divine commandments, presenting his work as such a meritorious endeavor. | Cf. Exodus Rabbah 17 — The author uses this reference to demonstrate divine acceptance of humble offerings, suggesting that his own modest work may similarly find divine favor despite its humble nature. | Cf. Exodus Rabbah 21 — This reference supports the author's hope that his teachings will endure and be studied in the messianic future, establishing the eternal value of Torah study. | Cf. Sefer Ha'Akedah — The author refers readers to these specific sections of the Akedah for additional perspectives on the afterlife and redemption of souls, suggesting alternative philosophical approaches to his own mystical framework. | Cf. Psalms 119:80 — This verse from Psalms expresses the author's prayer for single-minded devotion to Torah study without distraction from the evil inclination, revealing his spiritual aspirations. | Cf. Song of Songs — The author employs allegorical imagery from Song of Songs to represent the soul's preparation for its ultimate reunion with the divine, using the familiar bridal metaphor for spiritual perfection. | Cf. Psalms 84:5-7 — The author alludes to the soul's journey through death (the valley) before appearing before God, connecting his work to biblical precedents for describing the afterlife journey.

[ii] Cf. Traditional Hebrew text closings — This appears to be a standard Hebrew acronym used to conclude a text or section of a text with praise and acknowledgment of divine sovereignty. Such acronyms are common in Hebrew religious literature, particularly at the conclusion of prayers, books, or major sections. | Cf. Amidah prayer — The sentiment expressed in this acronym echoes the closing formulas of many Jewish prayers, particularly the Amidah, which concludes with affirmations of God's blessed nature and expressions of hope for divine will to be realized.

Part V

Appendices

Appendix A

The sefirotic system

In the mystical framework of Jewish Kabbalah that forms the theological underpinning of Aaron Berechia of Modena's *Ma'avar Yabok*, the sefirot (singular: sefirah) represent the primary conceptual structure through which divine energy flows into and sustains the created universe. Far more than abstract philosophical constructs, the sefirot in *Ma'avar Yabok* function as active channels through which human ritual actions—particularly those surrounding death, burial, and mourning—create tangible effects in higher spiritual realms. Understanding this system is essential for comprehending how the text conceptualizes the soul's journey after death and the efficacy of mourning practices.

The term "sefirot" derives from the Hebrew root *s-p-r*, connected to concepts of counting, telling, or recounting. This etymology reflects their function as discrete, enumerable manifestations of divine attributes that bridge the gap between the infinite, unknowable divine essence (Ein Sof) and the finite created world. As Aaron Berechia repeatedly emphasizes throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*, the sefirot constitute a complex divine system that humans can influence through properly performed rituals with appropriate intentions (kavvanot).

In kabbalistic thought, and particularly in *Ma'avar Yabok*, the sefirot are organized in a hierarchical structure often depicted as a tree or as a human form (sometimes called Adam Kadmon, or Primordial Man). This anthropomorphic representation is significant, as it establishes a direct correspondence between human actions in the physical world and their effects on the divine "body" composed of sefirot. When *Ma'avar Yabok* discusses ritual washing of the deceased's body, for instance, it simultaneously references the purification of corresponding aspects of the divine structure.

The sefirotic system represents a delicate balance of forces—particularly between judgment (din) and mercy (rachamim)—that requires constant maintenance through human ritual action. Death, in this framework, represents not merely a biological cessation but a cosmic event that disrupts this balance. The extensive rituals outlined in *Ma'avar Yabok* for handling the deceased and comforting mourners serve to restore cosmic equilibrium while facilitating the soul's transition through various spiritual realms that correspond to different sefirot.

What makes *Ma'avar Yabok* particularly significant is its practical application of this mystical framework to concrete ritual actions. Aaron Berechia repeatedly

emphasizes that physical actions performed with proper intention directly affect specific sefirot, creating effects that ripple through the entire divine system. A mourner tearing their garment, for example, is not merely expressing grief but performing an action that, when done with proper intention, helps release the soul from the "feminine realm" (associated with the sefirah of Malkhut) to higher sefirotic levels. This practical integration of mystical concepts into everyday ritual represents the pinnacle of applied Kabbalah in early modern Italian Jewish communities.

The intellectual triad: Keter, Chokhmah, Binah

The uppermost three sefirot—often called the "intellectual triad" or "supernal triad"—represent the highest and most abstract divine attributes in the sefirotic system. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, these three sefirot play crucial roles in the soul's journey after death, though they remain somewhat removed from everyday ritual practice due to their transcendent nature.

Keter (Crown) stands at the apex of the sefirotic tree, representing the divine will that precedes all manifestation. Aaron Berechia frequently refers to it using terms like "Ancient One" (Atik Yomin), "White Head" (Reisha Chivra), or "Supernal Crown" (Keter Elyon). As the closest sefirah to the infinite Ein Sof, Keter transcends ordinary human comprehension and is rarely accessed directly through ritual. However, in *Ma'avar Yabok*, particularly difficult cases—souls burdened by the most severe transgressions—require correction that reaches to the level of Keter. The text describes how certain deathbed confessions and funeral prayers performed with specific kavvanot (mystical intentions) can activate "the concealed holy White Skull" (Gulgalta Chivra Kadisha Stima), a reference to an aspect of Keter, to provide the most powerful spiritual remedy possible.

Chokhmah (Wisdom) represents the first flash of divine creative insight, the primordial point from which all subsequent creation unfolds. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Chokhmah is often associated with the "light of the Ancient One" (nehiru d'Atika) and the Father principle. The text describes how souls of the most accomplished Torah scholars ascend after death to draw sustenance from this exalted level. Chokhmah also relates to the "hidden light" (or ganuz) stored within the letters of Torah and prayer texts, which explains why *Ma'avar Yabok* places such emphasis on reciting specific biblical verses during deathbed and funeral rituals—each verse contains a spark of this primordial light that aids the soul's ascent.

Binah (Understanding) represents the divine womb where Chokhmah's seed-like insight expands into comprehensible form. Aaron Berechia frequently refers to it as "Supernal Mother" (Imma Ila'ah) or "Upper Eden." In the context of death rituals, Binah plays a particularly important role as the source of "thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil" (thirteen channels of divine mercy) that purify the ascending soul. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes how the soul must be immersed in these rivers before entering the Garden of Eden. The text explicitly connects several funeral customs to Binah, including the washing of hands after a funeral (symbolizing purification in these rivers) and the seven-day mourning period (corresponding to the "seven chambers of Binah" through which the soul ascends).

The intellectual triad collectively serves as the source of divine mercy that tempers judgment during the soul's posthumous journey. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains

that while the lower sefirot (particularly Gevurah) administer judgment to the deceased soul, the intellectual triad—especially Binah—provides the divine compassion needed to mitigate this severity. This helps explain the text's frequent emphasis on "sweetening judgments" (mituk ha-dinim), a technical kabbalistic term for transforming harsh divine judgment into mercy through proper ritual action that activates these higher sefirot.

One of the most important functions of the intellectual triad in *Ma'avar Yabok* is its role in the process of "death by divine kiss" (mitah bi-neshikah). Reserved for the most righteous individuals, this exalted form of death involves the soul being drawn upward by the intellectual triad rather than being forcibly extracted by the Angel of Death. The text describes this as the neshamah (highest soul level) being "kissed" by the divine and drawn to the "concealed Eden" associated with the intellectual triad. The deathbed recitation of the Shema prayer with proper kavvanah is described as facilitating this process, explaining why *Ma'avar Yabok* places such emphasis on this practice.

The emotional sefirot: Chesed to Yesod

The six sefirot positioned between the intellectual triad and Malkhut are often referred to as the "emotional sefirot" or "six extremities" (sheshet ketzavot). In *Ma'avar Yabok*, these intermediate sefirot play crucial roles in the soul's journey after death and in the efficacy of mourning rituals. They are frequently associated with the divine configuration known as Zeir Anpin (the "Small Face" or "Impatient One"), representing God's more immediate and accessible presence in creation compared to the transcendent intellectual triad.

Chesed (Loving-kindness), the fourth sefirah, embodies divine benevolence, expansion, and unconditional giving. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Chesed is frequently associated with Abraham and with the "right arm" of the divine structure. This sefirah serves as the primary source of mercy that counterbalances the severity of divine judgment at death. Aaron Berechia explains that funeral practices like washing the body and providing clean shrouds specifically activate Chesed, ensuring that the deceased receives divine mercy during judgment. The text also associates Chesed with morning hours, explaining why confession (vidui) and prayers for the ill are particularly effective during this time, when "the gates of loving-kindness open."

Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), the fifth sefirah, represents divine restriction, limitation, and judgment. Associated with Isaac and the "left arm" of the divine structure, Gevurah is the primary source of din (judgment) that the soul faces after death. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Gevurah is personified by the Angel of Death and the various "agents of judgment" (shlukhei ha-din) that examine the soul. However, Aaron Berechia is careful to present this judgment not as punitive but as a necessary purifying process. The text describes how various mourning practices—particularly the recitation of Tzidduk Ha-Din (Justification of the Divine Judgment)—serve to "sweeten" or transform the harsh aspects of Gevurah into constructive spiritual purification.

Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), the sixth sefirah, represents the perfect balance between Chesed's expansion and Gevurah's contraction. Associated with Jacob and the "torso" of the divine structure, Tiferet serves as a central mediating force

in the sefirotic system. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Tiferet plays a crucial role in the soul's journey after death, particularly for the ruach (middle level of the soul), which ascends to this sefirah. The text associates Tiferet with the "lower Garden of Eden" where righteous souls dwell after death, and with various ritual objects including the prayer shawl (tallit) placed on the deceased. Aaron Berechia explains that funeral prayers specifically directed toward Tiferet help unite it with Malkhut (Kingdom), facilitating the soul's ascent.

Netzach (Victory/Eternity) and **Hod** (Splendor/Glory), the seventh and eighth sefirot, function as a pair representing the extension of Chesed and Gevurah into more concrete manifestation. Associated with Moses and Aaron respectively, and with the "right and left legs" of the divine structure, these sefirot govern the prophetic transmission of divine will. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Netzach and Hod play important roles in funeral rituals, particularly in the seven circuits (hakafot) performed around the deceased's bier. The text explains that these circuits activate Netzach and Hod, helping to "break the shells" (klipot) that might impede the soul's ascent.

Yesod (Foundation), the ninth sefirah, channels the combined energies of the higher sefirot into Malkhut. Associated with Joseph and the "phallus" of the divine structure, Yesod represents the cosmic conduit of divine blessing and the principle of union. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Yesod plays a critical role in death rituals, particularly through the recitation of Psalm 91 ("Song of Afflictions"), which Aaron Berechia identifies as especially effective for activating this sefirah. The text explains that proper burial practices create a cosmic "union" (zivug) between Yesod and Malkhut, generating spiritual sustenance for the departed soul. This divine union is one reason why *Ma'avar Yabok* places such emphasis on gender separation during funeral processions—human separation paradoxically facilitates cosmic union between these masculine and feminine divine principles.

Together, these six emotional sefirot form what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls the "central column" (amuda d'emtza'ita) of the divine structure. The text repeatedly emphasizes how proper death rituals create balanced flow through this central column, ensuring that the soul's judgment (via Gevurah) is tempered by mercy (via Chesed) and harmonized through Tiferet. This balanced flow explains the careful structure of funeral prayers outlined in the text, which alternate between themes of judgment and mercy to maintain cosmic equilibrium.

Malkhut: the divine feminine

Malkhut (Kingdom), the tenth and final sefirah, occupies a unique position in the sefirotic system and plays an especially significant role in *Ma'avar Yabok*'s understanding of death and the afterlife. Frequently referred to as the Shekhinah (Divine Presence), Knesset Yisrael (Community of Israel), or the "divine feminine," Malkhut serves as the meeting point between the divine and earthly realms. Unlike the higher sefirot that remain transcendent, Malkhut directly interfaces with our physical world, making it the primary focus of most ritual actions described in *Ma'avar Yabok*.

Aaron Berechia frequently associates Malkhut with what he terms the "feminine realm" (alma de-nukba), a cosmic domain characterized by limitation, judgment,

and physicality. This association establishes a fundamental principle throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*—that death represents a transition from the "feminine realm" of Malkhut to the "masculine realm" (alma de-dekhura) associated with the higher sefirot, particularly Tiferet. The text presents numerous funeral and mourning rituals as mechanisms to facilitate this transition, helping the soul ascend from Malkhut to higher sefirotic levels.

Malkhut's relationship to death in *Ma'avar Yabok* operates through several key principles. First, Malkhut serves as the primary realm of judgment (din) that the soul encounters after death. While Gevurah (the fifth sefirah) is the ultimate source of judgment, this judgment manifests primarily through Malkhut. Aaron Berechia describes how Malkhut contains "courts of judgment" where the departed soul faces evaluation of its deeds. The text explains that funeral rituals like Tzidduk Ha-Din (Justification of Divine Judgment) specifically address these courts, acknowledging their authority while simultaneously appealing to higher sefirot for mercy.

Second, Malkhut is portrayed as the realm where the nefesh (lowest level of the soul) remains after death. While the higher soul components (ruach and neshamah) ascend to higher sefirot, the nefesh typically remains connected to Malkhut, often dwelling near the grave. This explains *Ma'avar Yabok*'s detailed instructions for proper grave maintenance and cemetery visits—these actions directly affect the nefesh in Malkhut. The text describes how reciting psalms and prayers at gravesites provides "nourishment" for the nefesh in Malkhut, which in turn benefits the higher soul components.

Third, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents Malkhut as experiencing "exile" (galut) when separated from the higher sefirot, particularly Tiferet. This separation intensifies at the moment of death, creating a cosmic disruption that funeral rituals aim to repair. The text explains that properly performed burial and mourning practices help "reunite" Malkhut with Tiferet, facilitating not only the soul's ascent but also a cosmic restoration. This restoration is described using technical kabbalistic terminology as a "unification" (yichud) between "the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence" (kudsha brikh hu u-shekhintei).

Fourth, Malkhut is associated with specific times and days that have particular significance for death rituals. Aaron Berechia explains that Friday afternoon and the eve of the new moon are times when Malkhut is most receptive to divine influence, making these optimal times for prayers benefiting the deceased. Conversely, the text warns that at other times—particularly Saturday night—Malkhut is more vulnerable to negative forces, requiring additional protective measures during funeral preparations.

Perhaps most significantly, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents Malkhut as the sefirah most directly affected by human ritual actions. Throughout the text, Aaron Berechia emphasizes that specific actions—from washing the deceased's body to reciting psalms to observing seven days of mourning—create tangible effects within Malkhut that reverberate throughout the entire sefirotic system. This principle establishes the theological basis for the extensive ritual practices detailed in the text, presenting them not merely as comforting customs but as cosmically efficacious actions with direct impact on divine realms.

The text also establishes a complex relationship between Malkhut and the concept of death impurity (tum'at met). Aaron Berechia explains that death creates a temporary withdrawal of divine light from Malkhut, allowing negative forces to en-

ter this realm. Funeral rituals—particularly purification of the body and recitation of protective psalms—help restore this divine light to Malkhut, driving away the forces of impurity. This restoration explains the text's emphasis on prompt burial and proper tahara (ritual washing) procedures.

Finally, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents Malkhut as the primary "gateway" through which souls enter higher spiritual realms after death. Using Jacob's biblical crossing of the Yabok River as a metaphor (hence the book's title), Aaron Berechia describes how souls must "cross over" from Malkhut to higher sefirot. This crossing requires "toll payments" in the form of good deeds performed during life or posthumous merit generated through charity and Torah study performed by survivors. The text explains that funeral and mourning rituals help "open the gates" of Malkhut, allowing the soul to ascend more easily to higher sefirot.

Sefirotic map of the human body and soul

A central principle throughout *Ma'avar Yabok* is the correspondence between the sefirotic structure and both the human body and the multi-layered human soul. This correspondence establishes a conceptual framework that makes the abstract sefirotic system tangible and applicable to physical death rituals. Aaron Berechia repeatedly emphasizes that physical actions performed on the deceased's body have direct parallels in the divine realm, affecting the soul's journey through the sefirot.

The text presents the human body as a microcosm of the divine sefirotic structure, with each body part corresponding to a specific sefirah. This correspondence appears most explicitly in the detailed instructions for the tahara (ritual washing) of the deceased, where Aaron Berechia prescribes specific biblical verses to be recited when washing each body part, based on its sefirotic correspondence. For example:

- The head corresponds to the intellectual triad (Keter, Chokhmah, and Binah), which is why the text prescribes verses from Song of Songs 5:11 ("His head is finest gold") when washing this area.

- The right arm corresponds to Chesed (Loving-kindness), requiring verses about Abraham (the patriarch associated with this sefirah) during washing.

- The left arm corresponds to Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), requiring verses about Isaac and divine power during washing.

- The torso corresponds to Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), requiring verses from Song of Songs 5:14 ("His body is polished ivory") during washing.

- The reproductive organs correspond to Yesod (Foundation), requiring verses about Joseph (the patriarch associated with this sefirah) during washing.

- The legs correspond to Netzach and Hod (Victory and Splendor), requiring verses about divine support and stability during washing.

- The feet correspond to Malkhut (Kingdom), requiring verses from Song of Songs 5:15 ("His legs are columns of marble") during washing.

This body-sefirot correspondence explains why *Ma'avar Yabok* places such emphasis on proper handling of the deceased's body. Actions performed on each body part directly affect the corresponding sefirah, influencing the soul's journey through the divine realms. The text warns that improper handling of the body—particularly leaving body parts uncovered or improperly washed—can impede the soul's ascent through the corresponding sefirot.

Equally important is the correspondence between the sefirot and the structure of the human soul. *Ma'avar Yabok* presents a complex model of the soul divided into multiple levels, each associated with different sefirot and experiencing distinct posthumous journeys:

- **Nefesh** (the vital soul): Associated primarily with Malkhut, the nefesh is the lowest soul level that remains most connected to the physical body. After death, the nefesh typically remains near the grave for a period, which explains the importance of proper burial practices and cemetery visits. Aaron Berechia describes how the nefesh gradually ascends through the "seven chambers of Malkhut" during the seven days of mourning (shivah), explaining the cosmic significance of this mourning period.

- **Ruach** (the spirit): Associated primarily with the six emotional sefirot (particularly Tiferet), the ruach is the intermediate soul level that ascends to what the text calls the "Lower Garden of Eden" after completing its purification. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that the ruach undergoes judgment primarily through these six sefirot, with the balance between Chesed (mercy) and Gevurah (judgment) determining its experience. The text details how specific prayers and rituals during the thirty days after death (shloshim) help the ruach navigate these sefirot.

- **Neshamah** (the higher soul): Associated primarily with the intellectual triad (Keter, Chokhmah, and Binah), the neshamah is the highest soul level that potentially ascends to what the text calls the "Upper Garden of Eden." Aaron Berechia explains that only the most righteous individuals' neshamot reach this exalted level, while most experience some form of purification before ascending. The text describes rituals performed during the first year after death as particularly beneficial for the neshamah's ascent through these highest sefirot.

Ma'avar Yabok also mentions two additional, more rarified soul levels—**Chayah** and **Yechidah**—associated with the highest aspects of Keter, but these remain somewhat abstract in the text's practical focus on death rituals.

This soul-sefirot correspondence explains the careful timing of mourning practices outlined in *Ma'avar Yabok*. The initial seven days (shivah) primarily benefit the nefesh in Malkhut; the thirty days (shloshim) primarily benefit the ruach in the emotional sefirot; and the full year of mourning primarily benefits the neshamah in the intellectual triad. The text explains that each mourning period creates specific effects in its corresponding sefirot, facilitating the associated soul level's journey.

Perhaps most significant is how *Ma'avar Yabok* connects specific ritual objects with sefirotic correspondences and soul levels. For example:

- The shrouds (tachrichim) correspond to Malkhut and benefit the nefesh.

- The tallit (prayer shawl) placed on the deceased corresponds to Tiferet and benefits the ruach.

- The atara (crown) sometimes placed on the deceased's head corresponds to the intellectual triad and benefits the neshamah.

This correspondence between physical objects, soul levels, and sefirot creates a comprehensive system where ritual actions in the physical world directly impact the soul's journey through the divine realms. By understanding these correspondences, those performing death rituals can ensure they are providing optimal spiritual assistance to the deceased at every level of soul and sefirah.

Masculine and feminine realms

One of the most distinctive features of *Ma'avar Yabok*'s kabbalistic framework is its consistent use of gendered terminology to describe cosmic domains and processes. Throughout the text, Aaron Berechia employs the technical kabbalistic terms "masculine realm" (alma de-dekhura) and "feminine realm" (alma de-nukba) to explain the soul's journey after death and the cosmic effects of mourning rituals. Understanding this gendered conceptual framework is essential for comprehending the text's approach to death and afterlife.

In the kabbalistic system presented in *Ma'avar Yabok*, the ten sefirot are organized into masculine and feminine domains. The upper nine sefirot, from Keter through Yesod, are collectively associated with the "masculine realm," while the tenth sefirah, Malkhut, constitutes the "feminine realm." This division reflects fundamental kabbalistic principles about divine energy flow, with the masculine realm characterized by active giving and the feminine realm by receptive containment.

Death, in this framework, represents a transition from the feminine realm (Malkhut) to the masculine realm (the higher sefirot). Aaron Berechia explains that during life, the soul is primarily bound to the feminine realm through its physical embodiment. At death, the soul must ascend from this realm to the masculine realm—a process the text compares to Jacob's biblical crossing of the Yabok River (hence the book's title). This transition forms the theological basis for the extensive ritual actions described in *Ma'avar Yabok*, which aim to facilitate this cosmic crossing.

Several key principles govern the relationship between these gendered realms in the context of death and mourning:

First, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents the feminine realm (Malkhut) as the primary domain of judgment (din), while the masculine realm (particularly Tiferet) serves as the source of mercy (rachamim). This explains why the text places such emphasis on "elevating" the soul from Malkhut to higher sefirot—this elevation represents a transition from judgment to mercy. Funeral prayers and rituals specifically aim to facilitate this elevation, helping the soul ascend from the "strict justice" of the feminine realm to the "compassionate judgment" of the masculine realm.

Second, the text describes these realms as normally united during life but temporarily separated at death. This separation creates a cosmic imbalance that funeral and mourning rituals aim to repair. Aaron Berechia explains that properly performed death rituals help "reunite" the masculine and feminine realms, described

in technical kabbalistic terminology as the "unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence" (yichuda de-kudsha brikh hu u-shekhintei). This unification benefits both the deceased's soul and the broader cosmic order.

Third, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents mourners as temporarily situated in the feminine realm (alma de-nukba) during the mourning period. This explains various mourning restrictions, including the prohibition against wearing tefillin during the initial days of mourning. Aaron Berechia explains that tefillin represent the masculine realm, and mourners—temporarily bound to the feminine realm—cannot properly integrate this masculine energy until their mourning period progresses. The gradual relaxation of mourning restrictions represents the mourner's reintegration of masculine and feminine energies.

Fourth, the text establishes a complex relationship between physical gender and cosmic gender in death rituals. While all human souls, regardless of physical gender, must transition from the feminine to masculine realm after death, *Ma'avar Yabok* provides some gender-specific instructions for death rituals. For example, it prescribes distinct confessional formulas for men and women, with women's confessions placing special emphasis on the three commandments traditionally associated with them: challah (dough separation), niddah (menstrual purity), and hadlakat nerot (candle lighting). The text explains that these gender-specific practices help each soul navigate its unique path through the masculine and feminine cosmic realms.

Perhaps most significant is how *Ma'avar Yabok* employs marriage metaphors to describe the relationship between masculine and feminine realms in the afterlife. Aaron Berechia describes the soul's posthumous ascent as a form of "spiritual marriage" between the individual soul and its divine source. For the righteous, this cosmic reunion is described as a "wedding feast" (hillula) in the upper worlds. This marriage metaphor explains why the text places such emphasis on proper burial shrouds, comparing them to wedding garments that prepare the soul for its divine union.

The text also establishes a theological justification for gender separation during funeral rituals based on these cosmic gender principles. Aaron Berechia explains that mixing men and women during funerals can strengthen negative forces by creating improper "unions" between masculine and feminine energies. Conversely, proper gender separation during funerals facilitates the appropriate cosmic union between masculine and feminine divine realms, benefiting the deceased's soul. This explanation transforms what might appear as a social custom into a cosmically significant practice with direct impact on the soul's journey.

Tiferet and Malkhut: central sefirot in death rituals

While all ten sefirot play important roles in *Ma'avar Yabok*'s understanding of death and the afterlife, two sefirot—Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony) and Malkhut (Kingdom)—emerge as particularly central to the death rituals described in the text. Their relationship forms a crucial axis around which much of the kabbalistic framework revolves, with numerous ritual actions specifically designed to affect these two sefirot and their interaction.

Tiferet, the sixth sefirah, occupies the central position in the sefirotic tree, balancing the right column of mercy (anchored by Chesed) with the left column of

judgment (anchored by Gevurah). In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Tiferet is frequently associated with Jacob, with the divine name YHVH (the Tetragrammaton), and with the "torso" of the divine structure. Most significantly, Tiferet is identified as the primary destination for the ruach (middle level of the soul) after death and is associated with the "Lower Garden of Eden" where righteous souls dwell.

Malkhut, the tenth and lowest sefirah, serves as the divine interface with our physical world and is associated with the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Malkhut is frequently identified with King David, with the divine name Adonai, and with the "feminine realm" (alma de-nukba). The text presents Malkhut as the primary residence of the nefesh (lowest level of the soul) after death and associates it with the grave and its vicinity.

The relationship between Tiferet and Malkhut is portrayed in *Ma'avar Yabok* through several key dynamics:

First, Tiferet and Malkhut are presented as the primary channels through which divine energy flows to sustain both the living and the dead. Aaron Berechia describes how proper death rituals create a balanced flow from Tiferet to Malkhut, ensuring that the deceased's soul receives spiritual sustenance. This flow is particularly important during the initial stages after death, explaining why the text places such emphasis on immediate post-mortem rituals.

Second, the text presents Tiferet and Malkhut as cosmic "husband and wife" whose proper union generates blessing for all worlds. Death temporarily disrupts this union, creating a cosmic imbalance. Funeral and mourning rituals aim to restore this union, described in technical kabbalistic terminology as a "supernal union" (zivuga ila'ah). The text explains that this restoration benefits not only the deceased but the entire cosmic order, elevating these rituals beyond mere social customs to cosmic imperatives.

Third, *Ma'avar Yabok* associates specific funeral prayers and rituals with Tiferet and Malkhut. The Kaddish prayer, recited by mourners, is explicitly identified as creating a union between these sefirot. The text explains that when mourners recite "May His great Name be blessed forever and ever," they specifically activate the flow from Tiferet to Malkhut. Similarly, the seven circuits (hakafot) performed around the deceased's bier are described as creating pathways between these sefirot.

Fourth, Aaron Berechia presents Tiferet and Malkhut as the primary sefirot affected by the ritual washing of the deceased (tahara). The text provides detailed instructions for this ritual, explaining that water poured over the body symbolizes the flow of divine energy from Tiferet to Malkhut. This explains why precisely nine measures (kav) of water should be used—this quantity corresponds to the nine sefirot from Keter to Yesod that channel energy into Malkhut.

Fifth, the text associates specific ritual objects with Tiferet and Malkhut, establishing a material basis for affecting these sefirot. The tallit (prayer shawl) placed on the deceased is associated with Tiferet, while the earth used in burial corresponds to Malkhut. Aaron Berechia explains that wrapping the deceased in a tallit before burial symbolically unites Tiferet and Malkhut, facilitating the soul's ascent.

Perhaps most significantly, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents death as a transition from Malkhut to Tiferet—from the "feminine realm" to the "masculine realm." The text explains that during life, the soul is primarily bound to Malkhut through its physical embodiment. At death, the soul must ascend to Tiferet and beyond, a process facilitated by proper funeral and mourning rituals. This ascent represents

not an abandonment of Malkhut but a restoration of proper flow between these sefirot, benefiting both the individual soul and the cosmic order.

The text also establishes specific times when the relationship between Tiferet and Malkhut is particularly potent for death rituals. The Sabbath is identified as a time when these sefirot are naturally united, explaining why prayers for the deceased are especially effective on this day. Conversely, Saturday night is described as a time when these sefirot temporarily separate, requiring additional protective measures during funeral preparations.

This central focus on Tiferet and Malkhut explains many practical aspects of the death rituals prescribed in *Ma'avar Yabok*, from the timing of prayers to the washing procedures to the recitation of specific psalms. By understanding how these rituals affect these two crucial sefirot, practitioners can ensure optimal spiritual assistance for the deceased's soul in its posthumous journey.

Sweetening judgments

A central theological concept that appears repeatedly throughout *Ma'avar Yabok* is "sweetening judgments" (mituk ha-dinim or bisum ha-dinim), a technical kabbalistic term for transforming harsh divine judgment into merciful correction through proper ritual action. This concept provides the theological foundation for many death rituals described in the text and offers insight into how the sefirotic system functions during the soul's posthumous journey.

In the kabbalistic framework presented in *Ma'avar Yabok*, judgment (din) originates primarily in the sefirah of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), the fifth sefirah associated with restriction, limitation, and severity. While necessary for cosmic order, judgment unchecked by mercy can become destructive. Death represents a moment when judgment potentially intensifies, as the soul faces divine evaluation of its earthly deeds. Aaron Berechia explains that funeral and mourning rituals aim to "sweeten" this judgment by activating Chesed (Loving-kindness), the sefirah of divine mercy that balances Gevurah.

Several key principles govern this process of sweetening judgments in the context of death rituals. First, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents judgment not as punitive but as purificatory. Aaron Berechia repeatedly emphasizes that divine judgment after death aims not to punish the soul but to purify it for ascent to higher realms. The text compares this process to the refinement of metals, where fire removes impurities rather than destroying the precious material. This purificatory understanding explains why the text describes even difficult posthumous experiences like Chibut Ha-Kever (the Beating of the Grave) as ultimately beneficial for the soul.

Second, the text explains that sweetening judgments requires creating proper balance between the "right side" (associated with Chesed) and the "left side" (associated with Gevurah) of the sefirotic structure. Aaron Berechia describes specific prayers and rituals designed to activate this balance. For example, the Tzidduk Ha-Din prayer (Justification of Divine Judgment) recited at funerals is described as simultaneously acknowledging the justice of God's judgment (activating Gevurah) while appealing to divine mercy (activating Chesed). This balanced approach "sweetens" judgment by integrating it with mercy.

Third, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents specific divine names as tools for sweetening

judgments. The text explains that reciting combinations of the names YHVH (associated with mercy) and Elohim (associated with judgment) creates cosmic effects that transform severe judgment into compassionate correction. Aaron Berechia provides detailed instructions for these recitations, including specific vowel patterns (nikudot) that enhance their efficacy. This explains the text's emphasis on proper pronunciation and intention (kavvanah) during funeral prayers.

Fourth, the text identifies specific ritual actions that sweeten judgments through their sefirotic effects. Charitable giving (tzedakah) in memory of the deceased is presented as particularly effective, as it activates Chesed to balance Gevurah. Similarly, the seven circuits (hakafot) around the deceased's bier are described as creating pathways for divine mercy to flow into judgment, sweetening its severity. Water used in washing the deceased symbolizes the "waters of loving-kindness" from Chesed flowing into the "fires of judgment" from Gevurah, creating balanced purification.

Fifth, Aaron Berechia describes how different levels of transgression require different approaches to sweetening judgments. For unintentional sins (shogeg), activation of Chesed within Yesod is sufficient. For intentional sins (mezid), Chesed from "the right side" must be invoked. For rebellious transgressions (pesha), sweetening must come from the highest level—"the concealed holy White Skull" (Gulgalta Chivra Kadisha Stima), an aspect of Keter. This graduated approach explains the multiple layers of prayers and rituals prescribed in the text, ensuring comprehensive spiritual assistance for all souls regardless of their condition.

Perhaps most significantly, *Ma'avar Yabok* emphasizes that the efficacy of sweetening judgments depends not only on the ritual actions themselves but on the intentions (kavvanot) of those performing them. Aaron Berechia repeatedly stresses that funeral prayers and rituals must be performed with specific mental focus on the sefirotic processes they aim to activate. The text provides detailed guidance for these kavvanot, explaining, for example, that when reciting certain psalms, one should visualize divine light flowing from Chesed to Gevurah, transforming judgment into mercy.

This concept of sweetening judgments transcends the individual soul's journey to address cosmic restoration. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that death creates a temporary cosmic imbalance, with judgment potentially dominating mercy throughout creation. By performing proper funeral and mourning rituals with appropriate kavvanot, practitioners help restore cosmic balance between these divine forces, benefiting not only the deceased but all worlds. This cosmic dimension elevates death rituals from mere personal comfort to universal significance.

Aaron Berechia also establishes specific times when sweetening judgments is particularly effective or necessary. Morning hours are associated with Chesed, making them optimal for prayers that aim to sweeten judgments. Conversely, afternoon hours relate to Gevurah, requiring additional emphasis on merciful intentions during funeral rituals performed at this time. This temporal dimension explains the text's detailed instructions regarding the timing of various death rituals.

Unifications and divine names

At the heart of *Ma'avar Yabok*'s kabbalistic system lies the concept of "unifications" (yichudim), technical mystical processes through which properly performed rituals create cosmic effects by uniting different aspects of divinity. Understanding these unifications and their relationship to divine names provides insight into how Aaron Berechia conceives the efficacy of death rituals within the sefirotic framework.

The term "unification" in *Ma'avar Yabok* refers primarily to the mystical joining of different divine names, attributes, or sefirot that have become temporarily separated. Death represents a moment of cosmic separation—particularly between the masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, or between the higher and lower sefirot. Funeral and mourning rituals aim to restore these cosmic connections, creating "unifications" that benefit both the deceased's soul and the broader cosmic order.

The text presents several key types of unifications particularly relevant to death rituals. The most fundamental unification mentioned throughout *Ma'avar Yabok* is the joining of "the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence" (kudsha brikh hu u-shekhintei). This technical phrase refers to the unification of Tiferet (representing the masculine divine aspect) with Malkhut (representing the feminine divine aspect). Aaron Berechia explains that this unification is temporarily disrupted at death but can be restored through proper funeral rituals. This restoration facilitates the soul's ascent while strengthening divine presence in the world.

A second crucial unification involves joining the divine names YHVH (the Tetragrammaton, associated with mercy) and Adonai (associated with judgment). *Ma'avar Yabok* provides detailed instructions for visualizing these names interwoven during certain prayers, explaining that this mental unification transforms harsh judgment into merciful correction. The text even prescribes specific letter patterns and vowel points for these visualizations, establishing a precise technical system for their efficacy.

A third type of unification connects the "upper unification" (yichuda ila'ah) involving the intellectual sefirot with the "lower unification" (yichuda tata'ah) involving the emotional sefirot. Aaron Berechia explains that comprehensive spiritual assistance for the deceased requires activating both levels. This dual activation explains the text's prescription of both philosophical contemplation and emotional expression during funeral rituals.

The mechanism for these unifications frequently involves divine names, which *Ma'avar Yabok* presents as direct channels to specific sefirot. The text establishes detailed correspondences between divine names and sefirotic forces:

- The name YHVH (the Tetragrammaton) corresponds primarily to Tiferet but contains aspects of all six emotional sefirot. Different vowel patterns (nikudot) for this name activate different sefirotic combinations.

- The name Adonai corresponds primarily to Malkhut and represents divine presence in the physical world.

- The name Ehyeh ("I Will Be") corresponds to the intellectual triad, particularly Keter and Binah.

- The name Elohim corresponds primarily to Gevurah and represents divine judgment.

The 42-letter divine name (often referenced by its first word, "Ana Bekoach") is particularly emphasized in *Ma'avar Yabok* for death rituals. Aaron Berechia explains that this name, divided into seven words of six letters each, activates all seven lower sefirot from Chesed to Malkhut. The text provides detailed instructions for reciting this name during deathbed rituals and funeral prayers, explaining its efficacy for "breaking the shells" (klipot) that might impede the soul's ascent.

The numerical values of divine names also play important roles in the unifications described in *Ma'avar Yabok*. The text notes that the numerical value of YaBOK (יב״ק) equals 112, which corresponds to the combined values of the divine names YHVH (26), Adonai (65), and Ehyeh (21). This numerical correspondence establishes the book's title as a cosmic formula for unifying these divine names, facilitating the soul's crossing from death to eternal life.

Aaron Berechia emphasizes that effective unifications require proper intention (kavvanah) during ritual actions. The text provides detailed guidance for these kavvanot, explaining, for example, that when reciting specific psalms or verses, one should mentally focus on uniting certain divine names or sefirot. This mental dimension explains why *Ma'avar Yabok* places such emphasis on the spiritual preparation of those performing death rituals.

The text also establishes specific ritual objects as physical vehicles for these unifications. The tallit (prayer shawl) placed on the deceased is described as embodying the unification of YHVH and Adonai through its structure and fringes. Similarly, the shrouds (tachrichim) represent the unification of the soul with its divine source. These material correspondences explain the text's detailed instructions regarding these ritual objects.

Perhaps most significantly, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents the recitation of the Shema prayer ("Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is One") as the ultimate unification, particularly when recited at the moment of death. Aaron Berechia provides extensive kabbalistic analysis of this prayer, explaining how its words and letters activate comprehensive unification across all sefirot. The text's emphasis on reciting Shema for the dying reflects this prayer's unique power to facilitate the soul's transition through cosmic unification.

Through these technical mechanisms of unifications and divine names, *Ma'avar Yabok* establishes a sophisticated mystical framework that transforms seemingly simple funeral rituals into cosmically significant actions. By understanding these mechanisms, practitioners can ensure that their ritual actions create optimal effects in the sefirotic system, providing the deceased's soul with comprehensive spiritual assistance in its posthumous journey.

The practical application of sefirotic wisdom

The sefirotic system presented in *Ma'avar Yabok* represents far more than abstract mystical speculation. Throughout the text, Aaron Berechia consistently demonstrates how this cosmic framework provides practical guidance for those caring for the dying, preparing the deceased, and comforting mourners. By understanding how human actions affect the sefirotic system, practitioners can ensure optimal spiritual assistance for souls transitioning from this world to the next.

Several principles govern this practical application of sefirotic wisdom in *Ma'avar*

Yabok:

First, the text emphasizes the profound interconnection between physical actions and cosmic effects. Simple rituals like washing the deceased's body, reciting psalms, or circumambulating the bier create tangible effects in the sefirotic system when performed with proper intention. This correspondence between physical and metaphysical realms transforms everyday ritual actions into spiritually powerful tools for aiding the deceased.

Second, Aaron Berechia presents the sefirotic system as accessible through proper intention (kavvanah) rather than reserved for mystical elites. While the text contains sophisticated kabbalistic concepts, it consistently emphasizes that ordinary Jews can activate these cosmic processes through sincere devotion and following prescribed rituals. This democratization of mystical efficacy reflects the text's practical orientation toward community needs.

Third, *Ma'avar Yabok* balances universal principles with individual variations in the soul's journey through the sefirot. While all souls follow similar posthumous paths through the divine realms, the text acknowledges that different individuals require different forms of spiritual assistance based on their lives and deeds. This explains the multiple layers of rituals described in the text, ensuring comprehensive coverage for all possible spiritual needs.

Fourth, the text presents death rituals not merely as comforting customs but as cosmic imperatives with universal significance. By properly facilitating the soul's journey through the sefirot, practitioners help maintain cosmic balance and divine flow that benefits all creation. This cosmic dimension elevates death rituals from mere personal concerns to universal importance.

Finally, Aaron Berechia emphasizes that proper understanding of the sefirotic system enhances rather than replaces traditional Jewish practices. Throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*, mystical interpretations serve to deepen appreciation for established customs rather than supersede them. This integration of Kabbalah with mainstream practice reflects the text's aim to strengthen rather than revolutionize Jewish death rituals.

The enduring value of *Ma'avar Yabok* lies precisely in this practical application of profound mystical wisdom to life's most challenging transition. By presenting the sefirotic system as a roadmap for the soul's journey after death, Aaron Berechia offers both spiritual comfort and practical guidance to generations of Jewish communities navigating the mysteries of mortality. The text's sophisticated yet accessible approach to death and the afterlife continues to resonate with readers seeking deeper understanding of traditional practices and their cosmic significance.

In this comprehensive integration of theoretical Kabbalah with practical ritual guidance, *Ma'avar Yabok* represents the pinnacle of applied Jewish mysticism—a testament to how profound cosmic wisdom can inform and elevate everyday religious practice, particularly in life's most challenging moments. By understanding the sefirotic framework that underlies the text's extensive ritual instructions, modern readers can appreciate the depth and significance of traditional Jewish approaches to death and mourning, finding in these ancient practices both practical wisdom and spiritual illumination.

Appendix B

The structure of the soul in kabbalistic thought

The Jewish conception of the soul, particularly as articulated within kabbalistic thought, presents a complex and nuanced model that extends far beyond simplistic notions of an ethereal counterpart to the physical body. In Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena provides an elaborate framework for understanding the soul's multi-layered composition, its journey through life and death, and its ultimate destiny. This appendix aims to elucidate the kabbalistic understanding of the soul's structure as presented in Ma'avar Yabok and related mystical Jewish texts, offering modern readers insight into this sophisticated system of thought that has profoundly influenced Jewish approaches to mortality, spirituality, and religious practice.

The kabbalistic conception of the soul represents one of the most developed and intricate aspects of Jewish mystical thought, evolving over centuries from biblical notions through rabbinic elaborations and reaching its most systematic articulation in medieval and early modern kabbalistic works. Within this tradition, the soul is not understood as a monolithic entity but rather as a complex, hierarchical structure of interconnected dimensions or levels, each with distinct qualities, functions, and cosmic significance. This multi-dimensional model offers a profound understanding of human consciousness, spiritual development, and the metaphysical journey of the human spirit across multiple planes of existence.

Ma'avar Yabok, composed in the early 17th century, stands as a particularly comprehensive exposition of Jewish soul doctrine, drawing upon earlier kabbalistic sources such as the Zohar, the writings of Moses Cordovero and Isaac Luria, and integrating them into a cohesive framework focused on end-of-life care, deathbed rituals, and the soul's posthumous journey. The text's detailed exploration of the soul's structure serves a fundamentally practical purpose: to guide those caring for the dying and deceased in performing appropriate rituals that address the specific needs of each soul component, thereby facilitating the soul's transition between worlds.

Understanding the kabbalistic model of the soul is essential for comprehending the rationale behind Jewish mourning practices, burial customs, and prayers for the dead. Each ritual element corresponds to particular aspects of the soul's structure and addresses specific spiritual needs during the complex process of separating from

physical existence and transitioning to spiritual realms. Without this conceptual framework, many traditional Jewish practices surrounding death might appear as mere customs without deeper significance.

This appendix will explore the hierarchical structure of the soul as presented in Ma'avar Yabok, examining each component's nature, function, origin, and destiny. We will investigate how these soul levels interact with physical existence during life, their progressive separation during illness and death, and their divergent journeys after physical dissolution. Additionally, we will examine related concepts such as the divine image (tzelem), the indestructible luz bone, spiritual garments, and the intricate connections maintained between the souls of the living and the dead. Finally, we will consider how this sophisticated understanding of the soul informed practical ritual guidance and shaped Jewish approaches to mortality, influencing everything from daily religious observance to end-of-life care.

The five-level structure of the soul

The kabbalistic tradition, particularly as articulated in Ma'avar Yabok, presents a five-tiered model of the soul that organizes human consciousness into a hierarchical structure ranging from the most material to the most transcendent dimensions. This framework, though rooted in earlier rabbinic conceptions, received its most systematic elaboration in medieval Kabbalah and serves as the foundation for understanding the soul's complex journey through life, death, and beyond. Each level represents not merely a component of individual consciousness but also connects to corresponding planes of cosmic reality, establishing profound relationships between microcosm and macrocosm, human existence and divine order.

At the foundation of this structure lies the *Nefesh* (נפש), the most basic soul-level associated with vital functions, physical animation, and bodily existence. The *Ruach* (רוח) constitutes the intermediate level, encompassing emotional capacities, moral intuition, and social consciousness. The *Neshamah* (נשמה) represents the higher intellectual and spiritual dimension, connecting the individual to divine wisdom and transcendent awareness. Less frequently discussed are the two highest levels: *Chayah* (חיה), representing the life-force that transcends individual existence, and *Yechidah* (יחידה), the singular point of unity with the divine essence.

Ma'avar Yabok elaborates on this structure, noting: "The soul has five names: nefesh, ruach, neshamah, chayah, and yechidah. These correspond to the five sefirot: Malkhut, Tiferet, Binah, Chokhmah, and Keter." This correlation between soul levels and divine emanations (sefirot) reveals the kabbalistic understanding that the human soul mirrors the structure of divinity itself, with each component reflecting and connecting to a particular aspect of the cosmic order. This parallelism establishes the theological basis for understanding the soul's journey as a process of progressive reunification with its divine source.

The text further explains that these soul levels are not equally distributed among all individuals. While every human possesses the nefesh by virtue of being alive, the higher levels must be developed or earned through spiritual practice, moral refinement, and religious observance. Aaron Berechia writes: "All Israel have nefesh from the realm of holiness… but not everyone merits to have ruach, which is attained through Torah and mitzvot. Even fewer merit neshamah, which is acquired through

deeper study of Torah's mysteries." This developmental model establishes spiritual practice as the mechanism for actualizing the soul's higher potentials, with each level of attainment representing a deeper connection to divine reality.

This hierarchical structure extends beyond individual spiritual development to encompass the community's collective religious rhythms. Ma'avar Yabok notes that during Sabbaths and festivals, additional soul dimensions temporarily descend to those who properly observe these sacred times: "On Sabbath, one receives an additional soul (neshamah yeteirah) from the supernal realm… on festivals, this illumination increases even further." This teaching establishes sacred time as a context for expanded consciousness, offering temporary access to higher soul dimensions that remain latent during ordinary experience.

The five-level soul structure also carries significant implications for understanding the process of death. Rather than conceiving death as the soul's abrupt departure from the body, Ma'avar Yabok presents it as a gradual unwinding of the soul's multiple layers. The author explains: "Thirty days before death, during the 'night of sealing,' parts of the soul begin to depart," followed by progressive separation of the remaining components. This understanding transforms death from a single event to an extended process requiring specific ritual support at each stage.

Understanding this five-fold structure provides essential context for comprehending Ma'avar Yabok's elaborate system of deathbed rituals, mourning practices, and afterlife conceptions. Each ritual element addresses particular soul components, facilitating their proper transition between realms. With this foundation established, we can examine each soul level in greater detail, exploring its nature, function, and destiny within the kabbalistic worldview.

The Nefesh: vital soul

The *Nefesh* (נפש) constitutes the most fundamental level of the soul, serving as the animating principle that vitalizes the physical body and grounds consciousness in material existence. In Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia describes the nefesh as "the lower soul that is clothed within the blood," drawing on the biblical association between nefesh and blood expressed in Leviticus 17:11: "For the life (nefesh) of the flesh is in the blood." This connection to blood and bodily functions establishes the nefesh as the soul dimension most intimately intertwined with physical existence, mediating between material and spiritual realms.

Ma'avar Yabok elaborates on the nefesh's composition, explaining that it comprises two primary powers: "The 'breath of the bones' (havla d'garmi), which is the natural heat that remains even after death, and the 'distress of the flesh' (atzvona d'bishrah), which is the sensing soul that experiences pain from decomposition." This bipartite structure reveals the nefesh's complex role spanning life and death, maintaining connection to the physical vessel even as other soul dimensions depart.

The nefesh serves as the foundation for basic consciousness, governing instinctual drives, physical sensations, and the automatic processes necessary for bodily maintenance. As the lowest soul level in the kabbalistic hierarchy, it corresponds to the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom), the final sefirah that manifests divine energy in the material world. This correspondence reflects the nefesh's function as the interface between spiritual and physical reality, translating higher soul impulses

into concrete action within the body.

Unlike the higher soul levels, the nefesh maintains a profound connection to the physical body even after death. Ma'avar Yabok states: "After death, the nefesh remains near the grave, hovering near the body and experiencing the process of physical decomposition." This ongoing attachment explains numerous Jewish burial customs aimed at providing comfort to the nefesh during this difficult transition. Proper burial in the earth, specific shroud materials, and the recitation of particular verses during funeral proceedings all serve to ease the nefesh's experience as it witnesses its former vessel's dissolution.

The text provides detailed information about the nefesh's post-mortem journey: "For the first three days after death, the nefesh remains near the body, hoping it might return… for seven days it travels between the grave and the house… for thirty days it ascends and descends between earth and heaven." This precisely calibrated timeline corresponds directly to Jewish mourning periods, with the most intense mourning practices (shiva) aligning with the nefesh's most acute period of transition.

The nefesh's connection to the grave explains why visitation of burial sites holds special significance in Jewish tradition. Ma'avar Yabok notes that when the living visit graves and pray there, "the nefesh of the deceased rejoices and ascends to inform the ruach, which then informs the neshamah, creating a chain of positive influence through all soul dimensions." This teaching establishes cemetery visits as not merely commemorative but actively beneficial for the deceased's spiritual welfare.

Though the nefesh represents the soul's most basic level, Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes its sanctity and significance. The text warns against certain burial practices that might disturb the nefesh's transition and prescribes specific prayers to assist its journey. The book's extensive treatment of proper burial procedures—from washing rituals to specific shroud preparations—primarily addresses the nefesh's needs during its gradual separation from physical existence.

The nefesh's inherent connection to the material realm makes it particularly vulnerable to spiritual impurity (tumah). Aaron Berechia explains that improper conduct during life "creates blemishes that adhere to the nefesh," necessitating purification through physical suffering during illness and spiritual cleansing after death. This vulnerability informs the text's emphasis on deathbed confession (vidui) as a means of purifying the nefesh before its departure, preventing prolonged suffering in posthumous realms.

Despite its attachment to the physical body, the nefesh ultimately seeks elevation to higher spiritual levels. Ma'avar Yabok describes how, after twelve months, "the purified nefesh ascends from the grave to the 'Court of Death,' where it begins its gradual ascent toward reunification with the higher soul dimensions." This upward trajectory establishes death not as the soul's final state but as a transitional process leading toward eventual reintegration and cosmic harmony.

The nefesh's journey illuminates the profound significance of Jewish mourning customs, transforming seemingly arbitrary time periods and ritual practices into meaningful accompaniment for the soul's complex transition. Understanding the nefesh's nature and posthumous experience provides essential context for comprehending Aaron Berechia's practical guidance for those attending to the deceased and mourning their passing.

The Ruach: emotional and moral soul

The *Ruach* (רוח), constituting the intermediate level of the soul's five-tiered structure, functions primarily as the seat of emotional experience, moral discernment, and interpersonal consciousness. Ma'avar Yabok describes the ruach as "dwelling in the heart," reflecting its association with emotional life and ethical awareness. This placement between the more physical nefesh and the more transcendent neshamah positions the ruach as a mediating force that integrates bodily impulses with higher spiritual aspirations, transforming abstract principles into lived experience.

In the kabbalistic schema presented in Ma'avar Yabok, the ruach corresponds to the divine attribute of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), the central sefirah that balances and integrates opposing cosmic forces. Aaron Berechia explains this correspondence: "The ruach connects to the six extremities governed by Tiferet, which is why it mediates between higher and lower realms." This cosmic parallelism reveals the ruach's function as an integrative force within human consciousness, harmonizing physical needs with spiritual ideals and reconciling opposing emotional impulses.

Unlike the nefesh, which every human possesses by virtue of being alive, the ruach requires development through conscious spiritual practice. Ma'avar Yabok states: "The ruach is acquired through engaging in Torah study and fulfilling the commandments with proper intention." This developmental aspect establishes the ruach as a dimension of spiritual attainment rather than an inherent human quality, explaining why individuals demonstrate varying degrees of emotional refinement and moral sensitivity based on their spiritual cultivation.

The text elaborates on the ruach's acquisition: "At education age, one begins to develop ruach by learning Torah's ways; at thirteen years, with greater responsibility, the ruach strengthens further." This progressive development aligns with traditional Jewish educational milestones and ritual coming-of-age ceremonies, suggesting that religious maturation directly correlates with the ruach's cultivation. During sleep, Ma'avar Yabok explains, "the ruach temporarily ascends to draw spiritual nourishment from higher realms," suggesting that even regular sleep cycles contribute to the ruach's ongoing development and refinement.

The ruach serves as the primary seat of moral agency, enabling individuals to distinguish between good and evil and motivating ethical action. Aaron Berechia notes that "the ruach experiences the pleasure of mitzvot and the pain of transgressions," establishing it as the soul dimension most directly engaged in religious and ethical decision-making. This moral sensitivity explains why spiritual practices aimed at character refinement (such as prayer, meditation, and ethical self-examination) primarily address the ruach's development.

After death, the ruach follows a different trajectory than the nefesh. While the nefesh remains connected to the physical body and grave, "the ruach ascends to the lower Garden of Eden (Gan Eden Tachton)," a spiritual realm corresponding to the World of Formation (Olam ha-Yetzirah). There, according to Ma'avar Yabok, "the ruach enjoys spiritual delights proportionate to its refinement through Torah study and mitzvot performed during life." This realm is described as filled with "rivers of pure balsam oil" where souls engage in continuing spiritual development and communion with other righteous spirits.

Despite this ascent, the ruach maintains connection with the nefesh during the transitional period after death. The text states: "During the first twelve months,

the ruach descends periodically to check on the nefesh's condition, particularly during Sabbaths and festivals." This ongoing relationship explains why mourning practices intensify during sacred times, when connections between soul dimensions strengthen, potentially increasing the deceased's awareness of earthly proceedings.

The ruach's intermediate position creates a unique responsibility as a spiritual messenger. Ma'avar Yabok describes how prayers offered at gravesides activate a chain of communication: "The nefesh receives the prayers and informs the ruach, which then transmits this awareness to the neshamah." This communicative function allows the ruach to serve as a conduit between material and celestial realms, connecting the most physical and most transcendent aspects of posthumous existence.

In the lower Garden of Eden, the ruach continues its spiritual development through what the text describes as "spiritual study in heavenly academies (yeshivot shel ma'alah)." These divine study halls parallel earthly institutions of learning but focus on deeper mystical dimensions of Torah accessible only to disembodied consciousness. The ruach's experiences in these realms depend directly on the spiritual knowledge acquired during physical life, explaining the text's emphasis on Torah study as preparation for posthumous existence.

The ruach also serves as the primary vehicle for ongoing intercession on behalf of the living. Ma'avar Yabok states that "the ruach of the deceased prays for living relatives, particularly during times of distress," establishing reciprocal relationships between the living and the dead. This intercessory function provides theological justification for prayers asking the deceased to advocate before the heavenly court, a practice detailed in several cemetery prayers included in the text.

Understanding the ruach's nature and function illuminates numerous ritual practices described in Ma'avar Yabok, particularly those focusing on emotional and moral preparation for death. The text's emphasis on resolving interpersonal conflicts, cultivating proper intentions during prayer, and maintaining emotional equilibrium during illness all address the ruach's specific needs during the transition from physical to spiritual existence.

The Neshamah: divine intellect

The *Neshamah* (נשמה) represents the highest regularly accessible dimension of the soul's five-level structure, functioning as the seat of divine intellect, spiritual illumination, and transcendent awareness. Ma'avar Yabok describes the neshamah as "the supernal soul, portion of divinity from above," emphasizing its direct derivation from divine sources. This description reflects the biblical teaching that God "breathed into [Adam's] nostrils the breath (nishmat) of life" (Genesis 2:7), establishing the neshamah as the most explicit connection between human consciousness and divine reality.

In the kabbalistic correspondence system presented by Aaron Berechia, the neshamah aligns with the divine attribute of Binah (Understanding), the third sefirah associated with divine intellect, comprehension of abstract principles, and the capacity for contemplative insight. This correspondence illuminates the neshamah's function as the soul dimension capable of grasping divine wisdom beyond rational categories, facilitating direct mystical apprehension of spiritual truths inaccessible

to ordinary thought.

The neshamah's elevated nature makes it the least commonly developed soul dimension among ordinary individuals. Ma'avar Yabok states: "Few merit to attain neshamah, which requires profound engagement with Torah's mysteries, pure intentions in divine service, and spiritual refinement beyond conventional observance." This rarified status explains why the text associates the neshamah primarily with exceptional individuals such as scholars, mystics, and those of extraordinary spiritual sensitivity who have cultivated receptivity to divine illumination.

Unlike the nefesh and ruach, which maintain some connection to physical reality, the neshamah exists primarily in spiritual dimensions. Aaron Berechia explains: "The neshamah does not fully descend into the body but rather 'shines upon' the individual from above, transmitting divine insight to the lower soul dimensions." This partial descent preserves the neshamah's purity while still allowing its influence to permeate human consciousness through mystical experiences, prophetic insights, and moments of spiritual clarity.

The text elaborates on the neshamah's developmental timeline: "At twenty years of age, one begins to access neshamah through deeper wisdom." This progression correlates with traditional Jewish educational patterns, where advanced mystical studies were traditionally reserved for mature students who had already mastered fundamental texts and developed moral stability. The delayed development reflects the neshamah's profound nature, requiring extensive preparation before its potentials could safely and effectively manifest.

During life, the neshamah serves as the soul dimension capable of experiencing devekut (mystical attachment to God), facilitating moments of transcendent awareness when ordinary boundaries between self and divine reality temporarily dissolve. Ma'avar Yabok describes how, during such experiences, "the neshamah perceives divine light directly, unmediated by lower faculties," creating states of consciousness that transform the individual's entire relationship to existence. These experiences, though typically brief during physical life, anticipate the neshamah's posthumous state.

After death, the neshamah follows a different trajectory than the lower soul dimensions. While the nefesh remains near the grave and the ruach ascends to the lower Garden of Eden, "the neshamah rises to the upper Garden of Eden (Gan Eden Elyon)," a spiritual realm corresponding to the World of Creation (Olam ha-Beriah). There, according to Aaron Berechia, "the neshamah enjoys the radiance of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) directly, basking in spiritual illumination beyond all physical metaphors."

In this elevated realm, the neshamah experiences what the text describes as "gazing through the illuminating lens" (aspaklaria ha-me'irah), a mode of perception that allows direct apprehension of divine truth without the distortions characteristic of physical existence. This direct perception represents the fulfillment of the biblical promise that the righteous will "behold the pleasantness of the Lord" (Psalm 27:4), establishing death as a transition to heightened spiritual awareness rather than diminished existence.

Despite its elevated posthumous state, the neshamah maintains connection with the lower soul dimensions. Ma'avar Yabok explains: "During sacred times, particularly Sabbaths, festivals, and Rosh Chodesh (new moon), the neshamah descends from the upper Garden to reunite temporarily with the ruach and nefesh." This

periodic reintegration creates moments of heightened posthumous consciousness, explaining why the text recommends intensified prayers for the deceased during these sacred times when the soul experiences momentary wholeness.

The neshamah's capacity for divine perception makes it the primary vehicle for posthumous intercession on behalf of the living. Aaron Berechia states that "the neshamah, perceiving divine intentions directly, can advocate before the heavenly court with greater efficacy than any living individual." This intercessory power provides theological justification for Ma'avar Yabok's numerous prayers invoking deceased sages, relatives, and Biblical figures as spiritual advocates, suggesting that the neshamah's elevated position grants it special influence in celestial realms.

In the upper Garden of Eden, the neshamah engages in what the text describes as "contemplation of divine secrets beyond those accessible to embodied consciousness." This continuous illumination fulfills the Talmudic promise that "in the World to Come, there is no eating or drinking, but the righteous sit with their crowns upon their heads, enjoying the radiance of the Divine Presence" (Berakhot 17a). The neshamah's experience represents the highest form of spiritual reward, where consciousness merges with its divine source while maintaining individual identity.

Understanding the neshamah's nature illuminates Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on specific deathbed practices such as meditation on divine names, recitation of mystical unification formulas, and contemplation of Isaiah's throne vision. These advanced spiritual techniques specifically address the neshamah's needs during the transition from physical to spiritual existence, facilitating its ascent to elevated realms and ensuring its proper reception in celestial dimensions.

Chayah and Yechidah: transcendent dimensions

Beyond the three commonly discussed soul levels (nefesh, ruach, and neshamah) lie two additional, more transcendent dimensions: *Chayah* (חיה) and *Yechidah* (יחידה). Ma'avar Yabok mentions these higher soul aspects less frequently, reflecting their extremely rarified nature and limited accessibility during ordinary human existence. Nevertheless, understanding these transcendent soul dimensions completes the kabbalistic model and illuminates certain mystical practices described in the text.

The Chayah, whose name derives from the Hebrew word for "living essence," functions as the animating life-force that transcends individual existence. Aaron Berechia describes it as "the soul dimension corresponding to Chokhmah (Wisdom), the second sefirah associated with the first flash of intuitive insight beyond discursive thought." This correspondence reveals the Chayah's function as the soul aspect that connects individual consciousness to universal life principles, facilitating moments of profound insight that seem to arrive from beyond ordinary mental processes.

Unlike the lower soul dimensions that operate within the parameters of personal identity, the Chayah exists partially beyond individual boundaries. Ma'avar Yabok states: "The Chayah dwells primarily in supernal realms, extending only a subtle influence into human consciousness during moments of extraordinary spiritual illumination." This transcendent quality explains why even advanced spiritual practitioners rarely maintain conscious awareness of this soul dimension, experiencing it instead as spontaneous flashes of wisdom that transcend their normal cognitive capacities.

The Yechidah, meaning "singular one," represents the highest and most transcendent soul dimension, corresponding to Keter (Crown), the supreme sefirah that exists at the threshold between divine infinity and manifestation. Aaron Berechia characterizes the Yechidah as "the singular point of unity between the individual soul and its divine source, where all distinction between creator and created momentarily dissolves." This profound unity represents the ultimate spiritual potential within human consciousness, though it remains largely latent during physical existence.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that the Yechidah "remains above in the supernal realms and does not descend into the body, but rather 'shines upon' the individual from its elevated position." This permanent transcendence preserves the Yechidah's perfect unity with divine reality while still allowing its influence to occasionally penetrate human awareness during rare moments of mystical elevation described in kabbalistic literature as "annihilation in divine unity" (bitul ba-yichud).

Though generally inaccessible during ordinary consciousness, these higher soul dimensions play significant roles in Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed practices. The text explains that at the moment of death, "as lower soul dimensions begin separating from the body, momentary awareness of Chayah and Yechidah becomes possible." This expanded consciousness explains reports of heightened spiritual perception among the dying, including visions of deceased relatives, angelic beings, and divine light described in both traditional sources and contemporary near-death accounts.

Aaron Berechia includes specific mystical practices designed to facilitate connection with these higher soul dimensions during the death process. He prescribes meditation on particular divine names, especially the 42-letter Name (Shem Mem-Bet) and 72-letter Name (Shem Ayin-Bet), explaining that these advanced techniques "awaken awareness of the soul's higher dimensions, preparing consciousness for the transition beyond physical limitations." These practices aim to expand awareness beyond individual identity into the universal dimensions represented by Chayah and Yechidah.

After death, these transcendent soul dimensions follow different trajectories than the lower aspects. While nefesh, ruach, and neshamah maintain some degree of individual identity in their respective realms, "Chayah and Yechidah return to their source in the highest divine realms, maintaining only subtle connections with the individual consciousness they illuminated during life." This return to source explains why Ma'avar Yabok's prayers for the deceased focus primarily on the three lower soul dimensions, which remain accessible to ritual influence.

Despite their elevated nature, Chayah and Yechidah maintain connection with lower soul dimensions through what the text describes as "subtle threads of divine light that extend from the highest realms down through all levels of existence." These connections allow moments of integration during sacred times when, according to Aaron Berechia, "all five soul dimensions temporarily reunite, creating profound spiritual illumination." This periodic reunification anticipates the complete reintegration promised in eschatological teachings about resurrection and cosmic restoration.

Understanding these transcendent soul dimensions illuminates certain mystical practices described in Ma'avar Yabok, particularly those associated with the most advanced stages of deathbed ritual. The text's references to "death by divine kiss" (mitah be-neshikah), characterizing the highest form of death where consciousness

merges seamlessly with divine reality, specifically relate to momentary awareness of Chayah and Yechidah during the transition. These practices transform death from fearful dissolution into the ultimate spiritual ascent, fulfilling the soul's highest potential.

The Tzelem and the Luz: bridges between worlds

Beyond the five-level soul structure, Ma'avar Yabok elaborates on two additional metaphysical components that serve as crucial interfaces between physical and spiritual existence: the *Tzelem* (צלם), or divine image, and the *Luz* (לוז), an indestructible physical element that maintains connection between body and soul after death. These components function as bridges between worlds, facilitating the soul's transition between physical and spiritual states while preserving essential continuity despite apparent dissolution.

The Tzelem, whose name derives from the biblical statement that humans were created "in the image (tzelem) of God" (Genesis 1:27), represents the spiritual blueprint or template that organizes soul energy into human form. Aaron Berechia describes the Tzelem as "the subtle body that clothes the soul, mediating between pure spiritual essence and physical manifestation." This intermediate structure provides the pattern through which formless divine energy assumes particular human shape, explaining the persistence of recognizable identity across multiple planes of existence.

Ma'avar Yabok distinguishes between the "upper Tzelem" (tzelem elyon) and "lower Tzelem" (tzelem tachton), corresponding to different levels of manifestation. The text explains: "The upper Tzelem belongs to the World of Formation (Yetzirah) and clothes the ruach, while the lower Tzelem belongs to the World of Action (Asiyah) and clothes the nefesh." This hierarchical arrangement creates a graduated series of interfaces through which soul energy progressively densifies as it approaches physical manifestation.

The Tzelem serves critical functions during both life and death. During physical existence, Aaron Berechia explains, it "filters divine light into forms accessible to human consciousness, preventing overwhelming spiritual intensity while preserving connection to higher realms." This protective function shields limited human awareness from direct exposure to unmediated divine energy, which kabbalistic texts describe as potentially destructive to unprepared consciousness.

During the death process, the Tzelem undergoes significant transformation. Ma'avar Yabok states: "Thirty days before death, in the 'night of sealing,' the upper Tzelem begins withdrawing, creating subtle changes in the person's appearance perceptible to those with spiritual sensitivity." This withdrawal explains certain physical changes observed in the terminally ill, including altered facial appearance, diminished physical presence, and the characteristic distant gaze often noted as death approaches.

The text provides practical guidance based on this understanding, instructing caregivers: "When changes in the Tzelem become apparent, preparations for death should begin, including confession arrangements and final spiritual teachings." This practical application transforms metaphysical knowledge into compassionate care, allowing timely spiritual support based on awareness of the soul's progressive sep-

aration from physical form.

After death, the Tzelem fulfills another crucial function that Aaron Berechia describes as "providing recognizable form to the disembodied soul in posthumous realms." This continued identity explains traditional beliefs that souls maintain recognizable appearance after death, allowing them to be identified by other deceased individuals and by the living during dreams or visions. Without the Tzelem, the soul would revert to formless energy, losing the individuality developed through physical existence.

The Luz, by contrast, represents a physical rather than spiritual bridge between worlds. Ma'avar Yabok describes it as "an indestructible bone, impervious to fire, water, or decomposition, which preserves the physical blueprint from which the body will be reconstructed during resurrection." This persistent physical element maintains continuity between the present body and its future restored form, addressing philosophical questions about identity persistence through death and rebirth.

The text presents varying traditions regarding the Luz's location, noting: "Some say it resides at the base of the skull, others at the base of the spine, and still others beneath the brain." Despite these anatomical variations, all traditions emphasize its indestructibility, with Aaron Berechia stating: "Even Nebuchadnezzar's furnace could not consume it, nor can any physical force destroy it, for it contains the divine spark from which physical existence will be renewed."

The Luz serves as the physical counterpart to the spiritual Tzelem, with Ma'avar Yabok explaining their complementary functions: "The Tzelem preserves spiritual form while the Luz preserves physical pattern, together maintaining complete human identity across the threshold of death." This dual preservation explains the text's emphasis on proper burial practices that respect bodily integrity despite the soul's apparent departure, recognizing that physical remains continue serving important metaphysical functions.

These bridging components illuminate numerous ritual practices described in Ma'avar Yabok. The careful washing and dressing of the deceased, the prohibition against cremation, and the emphasis on burial in the earth rather than above-ground entombment all reflect awareness of the Luz's ongoing significance. Similarly, prayers visualizing the deceased in recognizable form address the Tzelem's continued function as the soul's subtle clothing in posthumous realms.

Understanding these metaphysical bridges helps explain Ma'avar Yabok's consistent emphasis on maintaining connection between the living and the dead. The text states: "Through these persistent elements, channels of communication remain open between worlds, allowing ritual actions by the living to benefit deceased souls." This ongoing relationship transforms mourning practices from mere commemoration into active spiritual assistance, with specific prayers, charitable acts, and Torah study directly aiding souls in their posthumous journey.

The concepts of Tzelem and Luz thus resolve an apparent contradiction in traditional Jewish approaches to death. While acknowledging the soul's departure from the body, tradition maintains both respect for physical remains and belief in ongoing connection with the deceased—seemingly contradictory positions reconciled through these bridging elements that span physical and spiritual existence, maintaining continuity despite apparent dissolution.

The soul's journey after death

Ma'avar Yabok presents an elaborately choreographed account of the soul's posthumous journey, describing precisely calibrated timelines, specific transitional experiences, and diverse destinations for different soul components. This detailed cartography of afterlife experiences directly informs the text's ritual prescriptions, with each practice addressing particular aspects of the soul's complex transition between worlds.

The journey begins before physical death, with Aaron Berechia describing preliminary soul movements: "Thirty days before death, in the 'night of sealing,' parts of the soul begin withdrawing, particularly aspects of the upper Tzelem connected to the ruach." This gradual separation accelerates as death approaches, with the text noting specific signs of imminent transition: "When the soul reaches the throat, consciousness shifts between worlds, allowing glimpses of deceased relatives, angels, and spiritual guides coming to escort the departing soul."

At the moment of death, different soul components begin separate journeys. Ma'avar Yabok states: "The neshamah immediately ascends toward the upper Garden of Eden, the ruach begins its journey toward the lower Garden, while the nefesh remains with the body, experiencing the initial separation as significant distress." This divergent movement explains the text's emphasis on providing distinct ritual support for each soul component, addressing their unique needs during transition.

The nefesh undergoes the most complex transitional process, moving through precisely defined stages: "For the first three days after death, the nefesh hovers near the body, witnessing initial decomposition while hoping to return… for seven days it travels between the grave and the home, gradually accepting its new state… for thirty days it ascends and descends between earth and heaven, establishing new patterns of existence… for twelve months it undergoes purification before settling into its permanent posthumous dwelling."

These carefully defined periods directly correspond to traditional Jewish mourning stages: the three days of deepest mourning (sheloshim), the seven days of shiva, the thirty days of sheloshim, and the twelve months of saying Kaddish. Aaron Berechia explains this correspondence: "The mourning periods established by tradition align precisely with the soul's transitional stages, providing ritual support when most needed." This alignment transforms seemingly arbitrary time periods into meaningful accompaniment for the soul's journey.

The ruach follows a different trajectory, with Ma'avar Yabok describing its ascent: "After separation from the body, the ruach travels through what appears as a dark tunnel, eventually emerging into the light of the lower Garden of Eden (Gan Eden Tachton)." There, according to the text, "the ruach undergoes initial judgment, with angels reviewing its life record before determining appropriate posthumous experience." This judgment process evaluates actions, intentions, and spiritual achievements during physical life, establishing the ruach's specific placement within the Garden's hierarchical structure.

Within the lower Garden, the text describes hierarchical arrangements based on spiritual attainment: "The Garden contains seven chambers corresponding to different levels of spiritual accomplishment, with each soul placed according to its merits." This stratified afterlife reflects kabbalistic teachings about cosmic justice, where posthumous experience precisely mirrors spiritual development during phys-

ical existence, creating neither arbitrary reward nor punishment but rather natural consequences of soul cultivation.

The neshamah's journey extends furthest from physical existence, with Aaron Berechia describing its ascent "through multiple heavenly firmaments, each requiring specific 'passwords' in the form of divine names learned during life through Torah study and spiritual practice." This cosmic ascent explains the text's emphasis on studying divine names and mystical concepts during life, characterizing such knowledge as essential preparation for the soul's posthumous navigation through celestial realms.

Upon reaching the upper Garden of Eden (Gan Eden Elyon), the neshamah experiences what the text describes as "direct perception of divine reality through the 'illuminating lens,' without the veils and barriers that limited spiritual perception during physical existence." This heightened awareness fulfills biblical promises that "the pure of heart shall see God" (Psalm 24:4), establishing death not as consciousness's termination but as its expansion into more comprehensive spiritual perception.

For souls requiring purification, Ma'avar Yabok describes interim experiences in Gehinnom (often translated as "Hell" but more accurately understood as a realm of spiritual purification). The text characterizes this realm not as eternal punishment but as therapeutic cleansing: "Gehinnom purifies the soul through experiences corresponding to spiritual imbalances developed during physical life, removing accumulated negativity before the soul can enter eternal rest." This purification process typically lasts a maximum of twelve months (explaining the tradition of reciting Kaddish for eleven months to avoid implying the deceased requires the full purification period).

Throughout these posthumous journeys, Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes ongoing connections between soul components. The text states: "During Sabbaths, festivals, and new moons, soul parts temporarily reunite, with the neshamah descending to join the ruach, and both visiting the nefesh near the grave." This periodic reintegration creates heightened posthumous consciousness during sacred times, explaining the text's recommendation that cemetery visits and prayers for the deceased concentrate on these spiritually potent moments.

Aaron Berechia presents this elaborate posthumous journey not as speculative theology but as practical knowledge informing ritual practice. Each prayer, custom, and observance described in Ma'avar Yabok addresses specific aspects of the soul's transition, providing targeted spiritual assistance during critical phases. This practical application transforms abstract metaphysics into compassionate care, allowing the living to meaningfully support the deceased through properly informed ritual action.

The living and the dead: reciprocal relationships

One of Ma'avar Yabok's most distinctive contributions lies in its detailed exploration of the ongoing reciprocal relationship between the living and the dead. Rather than presenting death as an absolute separation, Aaron Berechia describes elaborate mechanisms through which actions in each realm directly influence the other, creating continuous circuits of spiritual exchange that benefit both the deceased and

those who remember them. This reciprocity transforms mourning practices from mere commemoration into active spiritual assistance while simultaneously establishing the deceased as potential intercessors for the living.

The text articulates this fundamental principle: "The dead are aware of the living and maintain concern for their welfare, while the living can actively assist the dead through properly directed spiritual actions." This bidirectional relationship explains the text's emphasis on both prayers offered for the deceased and prayers addressed to them, recognizing mutual capability for spiritual influence across the threshold between worlds.

Ma'avar Yabok describes specific mechanisms through which the living benefit the dead, with prayer serving as the primary channel. Aaron Berechia states: "When one prays at a grave, the nefesh of the deceased rejoices and ascends to inform the ruach, which then notifies the neshamah, creating ripples of positive influence through all soul dimensions." This chain reaction explains the Jewish custom of visiting graves during times of personal or communal distress, when the deceased's spiritual elevation might generate reciprocal benefits for those seeking their intercession.

Charitable giving represents another powerful mechanism for assisting deceased souls. The text explains: "When charity is given in memory of the deceased, with explicit verbalization that the merit should benefit their soul, this creates actual spiritual currency in posthumous realms." This transaction explains the tradition of establishing charitable foundations, scholarship funds, and community services in memory of the departed, transforming material resources into spiritual assets that accompany the soul through its afterlife journey.

Torah study conducted in the deceased's memory generates particularly potent posthumous benefits. Aaron Berechia states: "When someone studies Torah and dedicates the merit to a departed soul, this creates the equivalent of the deceased having performed the study themselves." This spiritual substitution explains traditions of completing Mishnah study in memory of the dead, with specific tractates chosen based on letters in the deceased's name to create personalized spiritual remedies.

The text emphasizes that these posthumous benefits depend on explicit verbalization: "When performing meritorious actions for the deceased's benefit, one must verbally state: 'May this be for the elevation of the soul of [name],' creating a directed channel for the spiritual influence." This explicit dedication transforms general positive actions into targeted spiritual assistance, explaining Ma'avar Yabok's frequent inclusion of dedicatory formulas within memorial prayers.

Reciprocally, the deceased actively assist the living through various spiritual mechanisms. Aaron Berechia explains: "The departed soul, no longer limited by physical constraints, can perceive divine intentions more clearly and access spiritual channels unavailable to embodied consciousness." This expanded awareness enables deceased souls—particularly those who achieved spiritual elevation during life—to serve as effective intercessors before the heavenly court.

Ma'avar Yabok describes specific circumstances when the dead intercede for the living: "During times of communal distress, the righteous dead arise from their resting places and plead for divine mercy on behalf of their descendants and communities." This intercession explains the Jewish custom of visiting graves during droughts, epidemics, and other calamities, when the deceased's advocacy might

prove particularly effective in arousing divine compassion.

The text presents biblical precedents for this intercessory relationship, noting: "When God remembers the covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, this reflects the continuing spiritual influence of the Patriarchs on behalf of their descendants." This ongoing efficacy of ancient merit explains the liturgical pattern of invoking the Patriarchs and Matriarchs during prayers, acknowledging their continuing role in sustaining the relationship between God and Israel.

Family relationships create particularly strong channels for posthumous influence. Aaron Berechia states: "A child's righteous actions directly benefit the parent's soul, elevating it to higher spiritual levels, while a parent's accumulated merit continues protecting descendants long after physical death." This intergenerational spiritual economy explains the emphasis on children reciting Kaddish for parents, establishing a reciprocal channel where the parent's nurturing of the child during life is balanced by the child's spiritual support after death.

The text describes physical mechanisms that facilitate communication between realms, with graves serving as "portals where the worlds touch most closely, allowing directed communication between the living and the dead." This understanding explains the Jewish custom of physically touching graves during visits, leaving written notes with requests, and prostrating oneself on the graves of particularly righteous individuals—all practices aimed at optimizing the transmission of spiritual influence across realms.

This reciprocal relationship transforms bereavement from passive suffering into active spiritual engagement. Ma'avar Yabok characterizes mourning practices not merely as expressions of grief but as "cooperative spiritual projects where the living and dead work together toward mutual elevation." This collaborative framework provides consolation by establishing continuing bonds with the deceased while simultaneously offering practical guidance for transforming grief into spiritually productive action.

Understanding this reciprocal relationship illuminates numerous ritual practices detailed in Ma'avar Yabok, from the recitation of memorial prayers to the custom of visiting graves on significant dates. These practices emerge not as superstitious relics but as sophisticated spiritual technologies designed to maintain vital connections across the threshold of death, allowing influence to flow in both directions for mutual benefit.

The soul's ultimate destiny

Ma'avar Yabok's elaborate model of the soul culminates in a vision of ultimate spiritual destiny that transcends even the complex posthumous journeys previously described. Aaron Berechia presents resurrection and cosmic restoration as the final chapter in the soul's narrative, when fragmented soul components will reunite, spiritual and physical dimensions will reintegrate, and the entire cosmic order will achieve harmonious completion. This eschatological framework transforms the soul's temporary posthumous arrangements into way stations along a more comprehensive journey toward universal perfection.

The text articulates this ultimate vision: "In the future resurrection, the soul's separated dimensions will fully reunite, the indestructible luz bone will regenerate

the physical body in perfected form, and consciousness will experience both spiritual transcendence and physical existence simultaneously." This integration resolves the tension between bodily and spiritual existence that characterizes the soul's earthly journey, establishing a perfected state where material and divine realms achieve seamless coordination.

Aaron Berechia describes the resurrected state as incorporating the best aspects of both physical and spiritual existence: "The resurrected body will maintain physical form but transcend material limitations, while the reunited soul will retain individual identity while participating directly in divine consciousness." This balanced integration represents the ultimate fulfillment of human potential, where neither physical nor spiritual dimensions are sacrificed but rather mutually enhanced through perfect coordination.

The text presents this resurrection not as arbitrary divine intervention but as the natural culmination of cosmic processes set in motion at creation. Ma'avar Yabok states: "The entire cosmic order moves gradually toward this perfected state, with each proper human action advancing this progression while each transgression temporarily delays it." This participatory framework establishes human activity as crucial to cosmic development, with ritual practices, ethical actions, and spiritual cultivation directly contributing to universal restoration.

Within this eschatological vision, the soul's complex structure and journey take on broader significance. Aaron Berechia explains: "The soul's division into multiple components serves temporary developmental purposes, allowing different aspects to undergo appropriate experiences across various cosmic planes before eventual reintegration." This developmental model characterizes the soul's fragmentation not as metaphysical tragedy but as necessary preparation for more comprehensive future unity.

The text describes how this ultimate destiny retroactively illuminates earlier stages of the soul's journey: "From the perspective of final resurrection, physical death represents not termination but transformation, not punishment but preparation for more expansive existence." This reframing establishes death as a developmental threshold rather than existential conclusion, helping readers interpret current experiences within a more comprehensive cosmic context.

Ma'avar Yabok connects individual resurrection with broader cosmic restoration, stating: "As individual souls achieve reintegration, the entire cosmic order undergoes parallel harmonization, with divine light permeating all existence without obstruction or limitation." This universal vision expands the soul's journey beyond personal salvation to participation in cosmic perfection, establishing individual spiritual development as contributing directly to universal completion.

The resurrected state represents not static perfection but dynamic integration. Aaron Berechia describes it as "continuous creative participation in divine reality, where perfected human consciousness actively contributes to ongoing cosmic development." This collaborative model establishes eternal life not as passive reward but as expanded participation in divine creativity, fulfilling the kabbalistic teaching that humans were created as "partners with God in the work of creation."

Understanding this ultimate destiny illuminates Ma'avar Yabok's practical guidance for current religious life. The text consistently presents ritual practices not merely as means for navigating death but as "rehearsals for ultimate cosmic harmony, training consciousness for its future expanded state." This preparatory frame-

work transforms religious observance from mere obligation into developmental practice, cultivating capacities that will find complete expression in the world to come.

The text's detailed attention to proper care for both body and soul reflects this eschatological awareness. Aaron Berechia explains: "Since both physical and spiritual dimensions will ultimately reunite, both require appropriate attention during their temporary separation." This balanced concern illuminates the text's emphasis on proper treatment of physical remains alongside spiritual care for the deceased's soul, recognizing that both contribute to the individual's comprehensive future restoration.

Ma'avar Yabok concludes its soul teachings with a profound theological affirmation: "The soul's complex structure and journey reflect divine wisdom, guiding consciousness through necessary developmental stages toward its ultimate destiny of perfected existence in both spiritual and physical dimensions." This teleological framework establishes the soul's current fragmentation and complexity not as metaphysical confusion but as intentional divine pedagogy, preparing consciousness for its future integrated state.

This vision of ultimate destiny transforms Ma'avar Yabok from mere practical manual for death rituals into comprehensive spiritual guidebook, addressing not only immediate needs surrounding mortality but humanity's broader metaphysical journey toward cosmic fulfillment. Through its sophisticated model of the soul, the text offers both practical guidance for navigating death and transcendent vision of existence's ultimate purpose, uniting immediate pastoral concerns with cosmic spiritual perspective.

Appendix C

The Four Worlds

Jewish mystical tradition, particularly as developed in the kabbalistic literature that reached its zenith in the 16th century, presents a sophisticated metaphysical architecture of reality that extends far beyond the material universe we perceive with our senses. Central to this cosmic vision is the doctrine of the Four Worlds (*Arba'ah Olamot*), a hierarchical structure of existence that describes how divine emanation progressively materializes through increasingly dense layers of reality. This conceptual framework provides the spiritual scaffolding that undergirds many Jewish mystical practices, particularly those surrounding death and the afterlife—as exemplified in the comprehensive ritual manual *Ma'avar Yabok* by Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena (17th century).

The Four Worlds doctrine represents a profound spiritual cartography that maps not only the cosmos but also the human soul's structure and its journey through life, death, and beyond. This mapping is not merely theoretical or speculative; rather, it serves as the foundation for understanding how ritual actions performed in the physical world generate effects that reverberate through the higher spiritual realms. For the kabbalists, and particularly for Rabbi Aaron Berechia, these rituals are not simply symbolic gestures; they are cosmic technologies with the power to facilitate the soul's transition through multiple dimensions of reality.

In *Ma'avar Yabok*, this kabbalistic framework underpins the entire approach to death and mourning rituals. The text's central metaphor—the soul's crossing of the "ford of Yabok" (an allusion to Jacob's transformative night crossing in Genesis 32)—represents the transition between worlds that occurs at death. The numerical value of YaBOK (יב״ק = 112) corresponds to the combined value of three divine names that themselves correspond to different levels of soul and different cosmic realms. This intricate correspondence between numbers, divine names, soul components, and cosmic dimensions is characteristic of the kabbalistic worldview that permeates Jewish mystical approaches to death.

Understanding the Four Worlds is essential for comprehending how traditional Jewish death rituals function as more than mere cultural customs or psychological coping mechanisms. From the kabbalistic perspective, these practices serve as spiritual technologies designed to facilitate the soul's navigation through complex cosmic territories. The washing of the body (*tahara*), the recitation of specific biblical verses, the circuits around the bier, and even the tearing of garments—all

these actions generate ripple effects through multiple dimensions, creating pathways for the soul's ascent and protection from harmful spiritual forces.

The correspondence between the Four Worlds and the components of the human soul provides a particularly important key to understanding death rituals. Just as the cosmos is structured in four descending layers of reality, the human soul comprises multiple levels that correspond to these cosmic domains. At death, these soul components begin a complex process of separation, with different aspects journeying to different destinations. The rituals performed by the living are designed to facilitate this separation process while providing protection and guidance for each soul component on its particular journey.

This appendix explores this cosmic framework in detail, examining how the Four Worlds doctrine illuminates the spiritual mechanics underlying Jewish death rituals. By understanding this metaphysical background, we gain deeper insight into the purpose and function of these practices, seeing them not merely as cultural traditions but as sophisticated spiritual technologies designed to navigate the complex territories that lie beyond physical existence.

The doctrine of the four worlds

The kabbalistic doctrine of the Four Worlds represents a comprehensive model of reality that describes how divine energy emanates from its infinite source, progressively condensing through layers of increasing materiality until it manifests in our physical universe. This cosmic structure is derived primarily from Isaiah 43:7, where God speaks of "everyone who is called by My name, whom I have created, formed, and made." From this verse, the kabbalists extracted four divine actions—emanation (implied), creation, formation, and making—that became the basis for the Four Worlds model.

At the summit of this hierarchical structure stands *Atzilut* (אצילות), the World of Emanation. This is the highest and most sublime realm, where divine energy first emerges from its infinite, unknowable source (the *Ein Sof*) into the beginnings of differentiated form. In Atzilut, the ten *sefirot* (divine emanations or attributes) exist in their purest state, still entirely unified with their divine source. This realm is characterized by perfect unity where no separation exists between Creator and creation—indeed, in Atzilut, everything remains fully divine. It is described in *Ma'avar Yabok* as "the world that is entirely Sabbath" (*olam she-kulo Shabbat*), a realm of perfect divine rest beyond all striving and effort.

Below Atzilut lies *Beriah* (בריאה), the World of Creation, where divine energy begins to take on more distinct form. Beriah is the realm of the divine throne (*Kisse ha-Kavod*) and the dwelling place of the highest archangels. Here, the first hint of separation between Creator and creation appears, though everything in Beriah remains primarily spiritual in nature. In this realm dwell the souls of the greatest tzaddikim (righteous individuals) who have achieved exceptional spiritual elevation. Beriah is often associated with pure understanding (*Binah*) and is sometimes described as the realm where divine thought first begins to take concrete form.

The third world, *Yetzirah* (יצירה), is the World of Formation, where spiritual forms become more distinctly defined. This is the primary angelic realm, inhabited

by various orders of angels including the seraphim, ofanim, and chayot—the beings described in Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot. In Yetzirah, the divine unity present in the higher worlds becomes increasingly diversified, with distinct forms taking shape. This realm is associated with the emotional attributes (*middot*) and serves as an intermediate zone between the purely spiritual domains above and the material world below.

Finally, *Asiyah* (עשיה), the World of Action, represents the realm of physical manifestation and tangible existence. In its highest aspect, Asiyah contains spiritual forces directly responsible for governing physical processes, while in its lower aspect, it constitutes the material universe that we perceive with our senses. It is important to note that Asiyah is not merely the physical world but includes spiritual dimensions that animate and sustain physical existence. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Asiyah is described as having both spiritual (*Asiyah ruchanit*) and physical (*Asiyah gashmit*) components.

These four worlds are not entirely separate domains but form a continuous chain of manifestation, with divine energy flowing from the highest to the lowest. Each world contains within it reflections of all the others, creating a complex, fractal-like cosmic structure. This interpenetration of worlds means that actions performed in the lower realms can generate effects that ripple upward through the entire cosmic system—a principle that forms the metaphysical basis for ritual practice in kabbalistic Judaism.

The Four Worlds correspond to the four letters of the divine name YHVH (יקוק), the Tetragrammaton.[3] The initial Yod (י) corresponds to Atzilut, the first Heh (ה) to Beriah, the Vav (ו) to Yetzirah, and the final Heh (ה) to Asiyah. This correspondence is significant because it indicates that the cosmic structure itself is a manifestation of the divine name—the cosmos is, in a sense, God's name writ large across multiple dimensions of reality. When rituals invoke divine names, particularly the Tetragrammaton, they are activating the corresponding cosmic forces across all four worlds.

In the context of death rituals, this cosmic structure takes on profound significance. Death, from the kabbalistic perspective, involves a complex process of soul components separating and journeying to their appropriate destinations across multiple cosmic domains. The rituals performed by the living are designed to facilitate this process, ensuring that each component receives the guidance and protection it needs for its particular journey. By understanding the Four Worlds structure, we can better appreciate how these rituals function as spiritual technologies designed to navigate complex cosmic territories.

Soul structure and the four worlds

The kabbalistic understanding of the human soul presents it not as a single, unified entity but as a complex, multi-layered structure comprising several distinct components. This conception mirrors the cosmic architecture of the Four Worlds, with each soul component corresponding to a particular cosmic domain. This correspondence provides the metaphysical foundation for understanding how death affects

[3] *Facilitator's note:* per tradition, I have not printed the actual Tetragrammaton. Instead, I have substituted ק for ה.

the soul and how ritual practices can facilitate its journey after physical demise.

The most common model describes three primary soul components: *Nefesh*, *Ruach*, and *Neshamah*. *Ma'avar Yabok*, however, frequently references a five-part structure that adds *Chayah* and *Yechidah* as higher soul components. These components are not entirely separate entities but represent different dimensions or aspects of a single, complex spiritual organism. Each component has its own characteristics, functions, and destiny after death.

The *Nefesh* (נפש) represents the most basic level of the soul—the animating life-force that sustains physical existence. It is deeply connected to the body and remains with it even after death. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Nefesh is described as having two aspects: the "breath of the bones" (*havla d'garmi*), which represents the natural heat that remains even after death, and the "distress of the flesh" (*atzvona d'bishrah*), which experiences the pain of decomposition. The Nefesh corresponds to the World of Asiyah and remains near the grave for a period after death, gradually dissipating as the body decomposes. Certain burial customs, such as placing earth from the Land of Israel in the coffin, are designed specifically to provide comfort to this aspect of the soul.

The *Ruach* (רוח) represents a higher level of soul associated with emotion, moral character, and interpersonal connection. This aspect corresponds to the World of Yetzirah and, after death, ascends to the lower Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden Tachton*). The Ruach retains the individual's personality and experiences both the pleasures of paradise and, if necessary, the purifying fires of Gehenna. Many of the prayers recited during the funeral service, particularly Psalms and verses that speak of divine mercy, are intended to facilitate the Ruach's journey and protect it from harmful spiritual forces during its ascent.

The *Neshamah* (נשמה) represents the highest aspect of the soul accessible to ordinary human consciousness. Associated with intellect, divine connection, and spiritual perception, the Neshamah corresponds to the World of Beriah and ascends to the upper Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden Elyon*) after death. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Neshamah is described as "the soul of the soul" and is associated with the highest levels of Torah study and spiritual attainment. Rituals that involve recitation of kabbalistic unifications and divine names, particularly the 42-letter Name, are specifically designed to elevate and protect the Neshamah during its post-mortem journey.

Beyond these three primary soul components, *Ma'avar Yabok* sometimes references the *Chayah* (חיה) and *Yechidah* (יחידה). The Chayah represents a transcendent level of soul associated with the living essence beyond individuality, while the Yechidah embodies the ultimate, indivisible unity with the divine. These higher soul aspects correspond to the World of Atzilut and beyond, and are typically beyond the reach of ordinary human experience except in rare moments of prophetic illumination or mystical union.

An important concept in this soul structure is the "lower image" (*tzelem tachton*), a spiritual template that mediates between the higher soul levels and the physical body. This tzelem has both internal and external aspects, with the external aspect departing thirty days before death (during what is called the "night of sealing"). The internal aspect remains until the moment of death, when it too departs, allowing the soul components to begin their separate journeys. Many deathbed practices described in *Ma'avar Yabok* are designed to facilitate the proper

dissolution of the tzelem and the orderly separation of soul components.

Also significant is the concept of the *luz* bone, a small, indestructible part of the body (variously identified as located at the base of the skull or at the bottom of the spine) that preserves a connection between the Nefesh and the body even after death. This connection serves as the nucleus for eventual resurrection, when the body will be rebuilt from this seed. The belief in this physical anchor for resurrection informs certain burial practices, particularly the care taken not to damage the body unnecessarily.

The correspondence between soul components and cosmic worlds creates a comprehensive framework for understanding death rituals. When a person dies, different soul components journey to different cosmic destinations, each requiring specific forms of guidance and protection. The rituals performed by the living—from the washing of the body to the recitation of particular prayers to the observance of mourning customs—are designed to facilitate these complex journeys, ensuring that each soul component reaches its proper destination and receives appropriate spiritual sustenance along the way.

Atzilut: the world of emanation and highest soul

Atzilut, the World of Emanation, represents the highest and most sublime realm in the kabbalistic cosmos. As the first manifestation of divine energy emerging from the infinite unknowable source (*Ein Sof*), Atzilut exists in a state of perfect unity where no separation between Creator and creation can be discerned. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Atzilut is described as "the world that is entirely Sabbath" (*olam she-kulo Shabbat*), indicating its nature as a realm of perfect divine rest beyond all striving and effort.

The spiritual landscape of Atzilut consists of the ten *sefirot* (divine emanations or attributes) in their purest form, still entirely unified with their divine source. These sefirot—Keter (Crown), Chokhmah (Wisdom), Binah (Understanding), Chesed (Loving-kindness), Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), Netzach (Victory/Eternity), Hod (Splendor), Yesod (Foundation), and Malkhut (Kingdom)—represent the primary channels through which divine energy flows into the lower worlds. In Atzilut, these sefirot exist in a state of perfect harmony and interpenetration, with each containing aspects of all the others.

Atzilut corresponds to the highest aspects of the human soul, particularly the *Yechidah* and *Chayah*. The Yechidah represents the ultimate, indivisible unity with the divine—the aspect of the soul that remains eternally connected to its source regardless of the individual's spiritual state. The Chayah represents the living essence beyond individuality—the soul's participation in divine life-force itself. These highest soul aspects typically remain in Atzilut even during life, descending only partially into the lower worlds and the physical body. In death, they return fully to their source in Atzilut, bringing with them the spiritual essence of the individual's life experiences and accomplishments.

For most individuals, these highest soul aspects remain largely inaccessible to conscious experience during physical life. However, the most elevated tzaddikim (righteous individuals) may achieve states of consciousness that allow them to access these sublime levels. Such spiritual masters are described in *Ma'avar Yabok*

as experiencing "death by divine kiss" (*mittat neshikah*), a form of passing that bypasses ordinary death processes and allows the soul to ascend directly to the highest realms. This elevated form of death, attributed in tradition to figures like Moses, Aaron, and Miriam, involves no suffering and represents a direct spiritual absorption into the divine.

Although Atzilut lies beyond the reach of ordinary ritual action, certain advanced kabbalistic practices are designed to create effects that reverberate even in this highest realm. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, specific meditations on divine names are prescribed for those attending a dying person, particularly focusing on the 42-letter Name (*Shem Mem-Bet*) and its seven component names (beginning with *ABGI-TATZ*). These meditations are believed to create channels for the soul's highest aspects to ascend safely to their source in Atzilut.

The concept of *yichud* (unification) plays a central role in these advanced practices. Through proper meditation on divine names and attributes, the practitioner aims to unify the divine masculine and feminine principles (represented by the Tetragrammaton YHVH and the divine name ADNY, respectively). This unification is believed to create a harmonious flow of energy through all the worlds, facilitating the soul's ascent. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the phrase "to unify the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence" (*leyachada kudsha brich hu u-shechintei*) appears repeatedly as the ultimate purpose of many deathbed and funeral rituals.

Atzilut corresponds to the Yod (י) of the Tetragrammaton, representing the initial divine point from which all creation emanates. This correspondence highlights Atzilut's nature as the primary source of divine influence flowing into the lower worlds. In the context of death rituals, invoking the Yod (through proper meditation and intention) activates the corresponding forces in Atzilut, creating a spiritual conduit for the soul's highest aspects to return to their source.

While ordinary ritual actions may not directly affect Atzilut, the kabbalistic principle that "the awakening below causes an awakening above" means that properly performed rituals in the physical world can indirectly influence even this highest realm. The purification of the body through *tahara* (ritual washing), the recitation of sacred texts with proper intention, and the performance of charitable acts in memory of the deceased all create ripple effects that ascend through the cosmic hierarchy, ultimately reaching even Atzilut and benefiting the soul's highest aspects.

For the kabbalists, and particularly for Rabbi Aaron Berechia in *Ma'avar Yabok*, Atzilut represents not just a theoretical cosmic domain but the ultimate destination for the highest aspects of the human soul. Death rituals, properly understood and performed with appropriate intention, serve as technologies for facilitating this return to source—ensuring that the divine spark within each human being finds its way back to the perfect unity of Atzilut.

Beriah: the world of creation and the Neshamah

The World of Beriah (בריאה), or Creation, represents the second highest realm in the kabbalistic cosmos, where divine energy begins to take on more distinct form. In this realm, the first hint of separation between Creator and creation appears, though everything in Beriah remains primarily spiritual in nature. Beriah is often described as the realm of the divine throne (*Kisse ha-Kavod*) and the abode of

the highest archangels, particularly Metatron, who is sometimes called "the lesser YHVH" because of his proximity to divine power.

Beriah corresponds to the sefirah of Binah (Understanding) and represents the realm where divine thought begins to take concrete form. The creative process referenced in Genesis 1:1—"In the beginning, God created (*bara*) the heavens and the earth"—refers primarily to this level of creation, where the initial differentiation from absolute unity occurs. In Beriah, the sefirot exist as distinct intellectual constructs, though they remain entirely spiritual without any material manifestation.

The human soul component that corresponds to Beriah is the Neshamah (נשמה), the highest aspect of the soul that is typically accessible to human consciousness. The Neshamah represents the divine intellectual essence within each person—the capacity for spiritual perception, abstract understanding, and connection with the divine. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Neshamah is described as "the soul of the soul" and is associated with the highest levels of Torah study and spiritual attainment.

After death, the Neshamah ascends to the upper Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden Elyon*), which exists within the World of Beriah. This upper Garden is described in *Ma'avar Yabok* as a realm of "hidden goodness" where souls experience direct insight into divine wisdom. The text describes how, in this realm, righteous souls study Torah directly from the Divine Presence, gaining understanding that was inaccessible during physical life. The Talmudic concept of heavenly academies (*yeshivot shel ma'alah*) where souls continue their learning after death is associated primarily with this realm.

The transition of the Neshamah to Beriah after death involves a complex process of purification and elevation. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, the soul must pass through the "River of Fire" (*Nehar Dinur*) before entering the upper Garden of Eden. This river, created from the intellectual "heat" generated by Torah scholars' debates, serves to cleanse the soul of any remaining spiritual impurities. The intensity of this purification process varies depending on the individual's spiritual state at death, with the most righteous experiencing it as a refreshing bath rather than a burning fire.

Several death rituals are specifically designed to facilitate the Neshamah's journey to Beriah. Particularly important are those involving the recitation of Torah verses with proper intention. The compilation of 112 verses corresponding to the numerical value of Yabok (יב״ק = 112) includes specific sections associated with divine names that correspond to the Neshamah's elevation. The first 21 verses correspond to the divine name Ehyeh (אהיה), which is associated with the sefirah of Binah and the World of Beriah.

The ritual of tahara (purification of the body) also contains elements specifically designed to facilitate the Neshamah's ascent. When washing the head, particular verses are recited that activate the corresponding spiritual channels. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the pouring of water over the head is understood as a physical analog to the Neshamah's immersion in the supernal waters of Binah, helping to cleanse it for its journey to the upper Garden.

The recitation of Psalm 90 ("A prayer of Moses, the man of God") during funeral services is particularly associated with the Neshamah's elevation to Beriah. Moses, as the greatest of prophets, represents the highest level of Neshamah attainment, and this psalm is believed to create a channel connecting the deceased's Neshamah to the spiritual level of Moses in the upper Garden. Similarly, the recitation of

kabbalistic texts like sections of the Zohar or Tikkunei Zohar is believed to create spiritual pathways through which the Neshamah can ascend to its proper place in Beriah.

The World of Beriah corresponds to the first Heh (ה) of the Tetragrammaton, representing the initial expansion and differentiation from the divine point of the Yod. This correspondence highlights Beriah's nature as the realm where divine energy first begins to take distinct form while remaining entirely spiritual. In death rituals, meditations on this letter of the divine name are believed to activate the corresponding cosmic forces, helping to draw the Neshamah upward to its source.

For those practicing the advanced kabbalistic techniques described in *Ma'avar Yabok*, specific visualizations involve seeing the deceased's name surrounded by divine light and ascending through the gates of Beriah. The text describes how each Hebrew letter of the person's name becomes a vessel carrying their spiritual essence upward, guided by the angels who govern the gates of the upper Garden. These meditations, performed with proper intention (kavvanah), are believed to create tangible spiritual pathways that assist the Neshamah's journey.

The ongoing relationship between the living and the dead plays an important role in the Neshamah's experience in Beriah. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, when descendants or disciples study Torah and perform good deeds in memory of the deceased, these actions create "crowns" for the Neshamah in the upper Garden, enhancing its spiritual status and expanding its capacity to receive divine light. This understanding provides the metaphysical basis for customs like studying Mishnah chapters whose initial letters spell out the deceased's name or establishing charitable foundations in their memory.

Yetzirah: the world of formation and the Ruach

The World of Yetzirah (יצירה), or Formation, represents the third cosmic realm in descending order, where spiritual forms become more distinctly defined and differentiated. This is the primary angelic realm, inhabited by various orders of angels including the seraphim, ofanim, and chayot—the beings described in Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot. In Yetzirah, the divine unity present in the higher worlds becomes increasingly diversified, with distinct forms taking shape that will eventually manifest in the physical world.

Yetzirah corresponds to the six sefirot known collectively as Zeir Anpin (the Small Face): Chesed (Loving-kindness), Gevurah (Strength/Judgment), Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), Netzach (Victory/Eternity), Hod (Splendor), and Yesod (Foundation). These represent the emotional attributes through which divine energy is channeled and modulated. The creative process referenced in Genesis 2:7—"And the LORD God formed (*yatzar*) man"—refers primarily to this level of creation, where spiritual forms are shaped and organized in preparation for physical manifestation.

The soul component that corresponds to Yetzirah is the Ruach (רוח), which represents the emotional and ethical dimension of human consciousness. The Ruach encompasses personality, character traits, emotional responses, and moral decision-making. It serves as a mediator between the higher intellectual Neshamah and the more physical Nefesh, translating spiritual insights into emotional responses and ethical actions. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Ruach is described as the aspect of the soul

that experiences both the pleasures of paradise and, if necessary, the purifying fires of Gehenna.

After death, the Ruach ascends to the lower Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden Tachton*), which exists within the World of Yetzirah. This lower Garden is described as a realm where souls experience spiritual pleasure appropriate to their level of development. Unlike the upper Garden in Beriah, which is characterized by pure intellectual illumination, the lower Garden offers delights that are more accessible to souls still connected to emotional experience. The text describes how, in this realm, souls enjoy the "radiance of the Shekhinah" filtered through various "chambers" (*heikhalot*) that correspond to different spiritual levels.

The transition of the Ruach to Yetzirah after death involves passing through various judgments and potential purifications. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Ruach must undergo a process called "Chibut ha-Kever" (the Beating of the Grave), where four angels examine the soul regarding its conduct in life. This process, more intense for those who lived unrighteously, serves to separate remaining impurities from the Ruach before it can enter the lower Garden. The ritual of seven circuits (*hakafot*) around the bier during funeral processions is specifically designed to protect the Ruach during this vulnerable phase, creating a protective spiritual barrier against the "external forces" that might interfere with its journey.

Several aspects of Jewish death rituals focus specifically on facilitating the Ruach's journey to Yetzirah. The recitation of Psalm 91 (known as "Shir Shel Pega'im" or "Song of Afflictions") seven times during the funeral procession is believed to provide special protection for the Ruach as it navigates the potentially dangerous territories between worlds. Each recitation corresponds to one of the seven lower sefirot, creating a complete circuit of spiritual protection.

The confession (*vidui*) recited before death is particularly important for the Ruach's journey. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, confession is described as having the power to transform the Ruach, allowing it to "pass from the side of impurity to the side of holiness." This transformation creates a spiritual alignment that facilitates the Ruach's ascent to the lower Garden. The alphabetical structure of traditional confession prayers (beginning with "We have sinned, we have betrayed…") corresponds to the 22 letters that, according to Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), are the building blocks of the World of Yetzirah.

The World of Yetzirah corresponds to the Vav (ו) of the Tetragrammaton, representing the vertical channel that connects the upper realms to the lower. This correspondence highlights Yetzirah's nature as an intermediary realm that translates higher spiritual energies into forms that can eventually manifest in the physical world. In death rituals, meditations on this letter activate the corresponding cosmic forces, helping to guide the Ruach through its post-mortem journey.

For those practicing the advanced kabbalistic techniques described in *Ma'avar Yabok*, specific visualizations involve seeing the deceased surrounded by the six directions (above, below, east, west, north, south) corresponding to the six sefirot of Zeir Anpin. This practice, called "setting a divine name in the six directions," creates a protective sphere around the Ruach as it navigates the complex territories of Yetzirah. Similarly, the practice of reciting the Shema at the moment of death, with specific meditations on divine unifications, is believed to create channels through which the Ruach can ascend safely.

An important concept related to the Ruach's journey through Yetzirah is that

of "sweetening judgments" (*mituk ha-dinim*). Many death rituals are specifically designed to transform the attribute of Judgment (associated with Gevurah in Yetzirah) into Mercy (associated with Chesed). The recitation of specific divine names, the performance of charitable acts, and the study of Torah in memory of the deceased are all believed to effect this transformation, ensuring that the Ruach encounters merciful rather than severe judgment during its ascent.

The relationship between the living and the dead also operates strongly at the level of Ruach and Yetzirah. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, when mourners recite Kaddish or perform mitzvot in memory of the deceased, these actions create "garments of light" for the Ruach in the lower Garden. These spiritual garments enhance the Ruach's capacity to receive divine illumination and protect it from the potentially overwhelming intensity of spiritual light in Yetzirah. This understanding provides the metaphysical basis for the emphasis on Kaddish recitation during the eleven-month mourning period.

Asiyah: the world of action and the Nefesh

The World of Asiyah (עשיה), or Action, represents the lowest of the four cosmic realms, where divine energy manifests in tangible, physical form. In its highest aspect, Asiyah contains spiritual forces directly responsible for governing physical processes, while in its lower aspect, it constitutes the material universe that we perceive with our senses. The name Asiyah derives from the Hebrew verb "to make" or "to do" (עשה), reflecting this world's focus on concrete manifestation and action rather than abstract thought or emotion.

Asiyah corresponds primarily to the sefirah of Malkhut (Kingdom), which represents the final stage in the downward flow of divine energy. In Malkhut, the creative potential present in the higher sefirot becomes actualized in the physical world. The creative process referenced in Genesis 2:2—"And on the seventh day God completed His work (*melakhto*) which He had made (*asah*)"—refers to this level of creation, where divine energy finally takes material form.

The soul component that corresponds to Asiyah is the Nefesh (נפש), which represents the most basic level of the soul—the animating life-force that sustains physical existence. The Nefesh is deeply connected to the body and remains with it even after death for a certain period. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Nefesh is described as having two aspects: the "breath of the bones" (*havla d'garmi*), which represents the natural heat that remains even after death, and the "distress of the flesh" (*atzvona d'bishrah*), which experiences the pain of decomposition.

After death, the Nefesh initially remains near the grave, gradually disconnecting from the body as it decomposes. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, the Nefesh hovers near the body for the first three days after death (when decomposition is most intense), gradually ascending to a realm called "the Court of Death" (*Chatzer Mavet*). This realm exists within the World of Asiyah and serves as a transitional space where the Nefesh begins to adjust to existence without the physical body. The thirty-day mourning period (*sheloshim*) corresponds to the Nefesh's gradual ascent through the thirty spiritual levels that separate Asiyah from the higher worlds.

An important concept related to the Nefesh's post-mortem experience is that of the *luz* bone—a small, indestructible part of the body (variously identified as

located at the base of the skull or at the bottom of the spine) that preserves a connection between the Nefesh and the body even after death. This connection serves as the nucleus for eventual resurrection, when the body will be rebuilt from this seed. The belief in this physical anchor for resurrection informs certain burial practices, particularly the care taken not to damage the body unnecessarily.

Many aspects of Jewish burial practices focus specifically on providing comfort and protection for the Nefesh during its transitional period. The washing of the body (*tahara*) is understood not merely as a physical cleansing but as a spiritual purification that benefits the Nefesh. The recitation of specific verses during the washing of different body parts creates a correspondence between physical cleansing and spiritual purification, helping to free the Nefesh from its attachment to the body.

The custom of burial in a simple wooden coffin, rather than an elaborate metal one, is related to the concept that the body should return to the earth as quickly as possible. This facilitates the Nefesh's gradual release from its physical attachment. Similarly, the prohibition against embalming in traditional Jewish practice stems from the understanding that artificial preservation of the body prolongs the Nefesh's attachment, potentially causing it distress.

The recitation of Psalms at the graveside, particularly Psalm 91, is believed to provide protection for the Nefesh during its vulnerable transitional period. The custom of placing earth from the Land of Israel in the coffin is understood to provide comfort to the Nefesh, connecting it to the sacred soil that will play a role in resurrection. Similarly, the practice of building a proper tombstone (typically after the first year) serves both as a marker for the living and as a "dwelling place" for the Nefesh when it visits the grave.

The World of Asiyah corresponds to the final Heh (ה) of the Tetragrammaton, representing the manifestation and actualization of divine potential. This correspondence highlights Asiyah's nature as the realm where divine energy completes its journey from potential to actual, from abstract to concrete. In death rituals, meditations on this letter activate the corresponding cosmic forces, helping to provide comfort and protection for the Nefesh in its transitional state.

For those practicing the advanced kabbalistic techniques described in *Ma'avar Yabok*, specific visualizations involve seeing the deceased's body surrounded by divine light, with each organ connected to its corresponding spiritual source. This practice, called "unifying the dwellings" (*yichud ha-mezuzot*), helps to disentangle the Nefesh from its physical attachments while maintaining the essential connection through the luz bone that will enable eventual resurrection.

The relationship between the living and the dead also operates at the level of Nefesh and Asiyah. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, when mourners visit the grave and pray there, their presence provides comfort to the Nefesh, particularly during the first year after death when the connection to the physical world remains strongest. The custom of placing small stones on the grave during visits serves as a tangible marker of this ongoing connection between the living and the dead in the physical realm of Asiyah.

An important concept related to the Nefesh's experience in Asiyah after death is that of "Chibut ha-Kever" (the Beating of the Grave). This process, which primarily affects the Nefesh, involves a reckoning with the physical actions performed during life. The intensity of this process varies depending on the individual's conduct, with those who lived righteously experiencing it as a mild purification rather than

a painful punishment. Many burial customs, such as the placement of the body directly in contact with the earth rather than in an elaborate casket, are designed to mitigate the intensity of Chibut ha-Kever.

The soul's journey through the four worlds

The kabbalistic doctrine of the Four Worlds, when integrated with the understanding of the soul's multi-layered structure, provides a comprehensive framework for understanding the spiritual mechanics of death and the purpose of associated rituals. After death, the soul components embark on distinct but interconnected journeys through the cosmic hierarchy, each requiring specific forms of guidance and protection. Jewish death rituals, as codified in works like *Ma'avar Yabok*, are designed as spiritual technologies to facilitate these complex journeys.

The process begins even before physical death occurs. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, thirty days before death (during what is called the "night of sealing"), the external aspect of the tzelem (spiritual image) begins to separate from the body. This initial separation may manifest as changes in the person's appearance or demeanor, often noticed by those with spiritual sensitivity. As death approaches, the internal aspect of the tzelem also begins to withdraw, allowing the soul components to prepare for their separate journeys.

At the moment of death, a complex process of separation begins. The highest aspects of the soul—Yechidah and Chayah—which correspond to the World of Atzilut, return fully to their divine source. For most individuals, these aspects have remained primarily in Atzilut even during life, descending only partially into the lower worlds. Their return represents the reunification of the divine spark with its source.

The Neshamah, corresponding to the World of Beriah, begins its ascent to the upper Garden of Eden. This journey involves passing through the "River of Fire" (*Nehar Dinur*), a purification process whose intensity varies depending on the individual's spiritual state. For the righteous, this river appears as a refreshing bath; for others, it may involve more intense purification. In the upper Garden, the Neshamah experiences direct insight into divine wisdom, studying Torah from the Divine Presence itself.

The Ruach, corresponding to the World of Yetzirah, undergoes a process called "Chibut ha-Kever" (the Beating of the Grave), where four angels examine the soul regarding its conduct in life. After this examination, the Ruach ascends to the lower Garden of Eden, where it experiences spiritual pleasure appropriate to its level of development. If necessary, the Ruach may undergo periods in Gehenna for purification before entering the Garden.

The Nefesh, corresponding to the World of Asiyah, initially remains near the grave, gradually disconnecting from the body as it decomposes. Over time, the Nefesh ascends through thirty spiritual levels until it reaches the "Court of Death," a transitional realm within Asiyah. A small connection remains through the luz bone, which will serve as the nucleus for eventual resurrection.

During this complex separation and ascension process, the soul components remain connected to each other through spiritual "threads" or "cords." On Sabbaths, festivals, and other sacred occasions, these components may temporarily

reunite, allowing the soul to experience more complete spiritual awareness. This understanding informs the custom of reciting special prayers for the deceased on Sabbaths and festivals, when the soul's components are in a state of greater unity and more receptive to spiritual influence.

The rituals performed by the living play a crucial role in facilitating these complex journeys. The confession (*vidui*) recited before death prepares the soul for its transition, creating spiritual alignments that will assist its passage through the cosmic hierarchy. The washing of the body (*tahara*) after death serves as a physical analog to the spiritual purification processes that the soul undergoes, with specific verses recited for different body parts creating correspondences between physical and spiritual cleansing.

The funeral service, with its psalms, prayers, and eulogies, provides spiritual protection for the soul during its vulnerable transitional period. The seven circuits (*hakafot*) around the bier create a protective spiritual barrier against the "external forces" that might interfere with the soul's journey. The recitation of the Tzidduk ha-Din ("Justification of Divine Judgment") prayer acknowledges the righteousness of God's decree while seeking mercy for the departed soul.

After burial, the mourning practices observed by the living continue to provide support for the soul's journey. The seven-day shiva period corresponds to the soul's passage through seven spiritual chambers or gates. The thirty-day sheloshim period parallels the Nefesh's ascent through thirty spiritual levels. The recitation of Kaddish during the eleven-month mourning period creates "garments of light" for the Ruach in the lower Garden of Eden.

The ongoing relationship between the living and the dead operates across all four cosmic worlds. When descendants or disciples study Torah and perform good deeds in memory of the deceased, these actions create "crowns" for the Neshamah in the upper Garden, enhancing its spiritual status. Charitable acts performed in the deceased's name generate "merit" (*zechut*) that assists the soul at all levels of its journey, from the Nefesh in Asiyah to the highest aspects in Atzilut.

Understanding this complex cosmic framework reveals the profound spiritual technology embedded in Jewish death rituals. These practices are not merely cultural customs or psychological coping mechanisms; they are sophisticated spiritual tools designed to navigate the complex territories that lie beyond physical existence. From the washing of the body to the recitation of Kaddish, each ritual element serves a specific function in facilitating the soul's journey through the Four Worlds.

For the kabbalists, and particularly for Rabbi Aaron Berechia in *Ma'avar Yabok*, this understanding transforms death from a tragedy to be feared into a transition to be navigated with wisdom and precision. Just as Jacob crossed the ford of Yabok before his transformative encounter with the divine, so too does the soul cross the metaphysical "ford" between worlds—a crossing that, when properly facilitated through ritual action, leads to spiritual elevation and the fulfillment of the soul's cosmic purpose.

Appendix D

Divine names and their mystical functions

In Jewish mystical thought, divine names represent more than mere designations for the Deity—they are understood as active channels of divine power that mediate between human consciousness and the infinite divine reality. Ma'avar Yabok, Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena's comprehensive guide to Jewish death rituals, presents divine names as essential components in facilitating the soul's transition from this world to the next. Throughout the text, these names function not merely as appellations but as mystical instruments with distinct metaphysical properties, each associated with different aspects of the divine and serving specific functions in death rituals.

The kabbalistic understanding of divine names presupposes that Hebrew letters possess intrinsic cosmic potency, embodying creative forces through which God brought the world into existence. As the Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation) states, God "engraved and created His world with three books (sefarim): with text (sefer), with number (sefar), and with communication (sippur)." This foundational concept establishes Hebrew letters and their combinations as both the building blocks of creation and the means through which humans can interact with divine realms. In Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia draws extensively on this tradition, integrating divine names into every aspect of deathbed, funeral, and mourning rituals.

The mystical approach to divine names derives primarily from the Zohar and later kabbalistic works, particularly those influenced by Lurianic Kabbalah. Rabbi Aaron Berechia, who identifies Rabbi Menahem Azariah da Fano as his teacher, stands firmly within this tradition. His systematic application of divine names in death rituals reflects the belief that these names provide access points to different aspects of divinity, allowing humans to navigate the complex relationship between divine mercy and judgment that becomes particularly acute at the moment of death.

Ma'avar Yabok presents death as a spiritual transition rather than merely a biological cessation, requiring precise ritual actions with proper mystical intentions (*kavvanot*) to ensure the soul's safe passage. Divine names constitute the core of these intentions, with each name corresponding to specific divine attributes, cosmic realms, and soul components. The proper invocation of these names, according to the text, creates metaphysical pathways for the soul's ascent, mitigates harsh

judgments, and establishes protective shields against negative spiritual forces.

This appendix explores the principal divine names appearing in Ma'avar Yabok, examining their origins, specific functions in death rituals, and the complex system of correspondences through which they operate. We will see how Aaron Berechia integrates earlier kabbalistic traditions into a comprehensive framework that guides religious practitioners through every stage of death-related rituals, from attending the deathbed to post-burial practices. Understanding this system of divine names provides essential context for comprehending the metaphysical dimensions of Jewish death rituals as presented in Ma'avar Yabok.

The tetragrammaton (YHVH) in death rituals

The four-letter divine name YHVH (יהו״ה), traditionally referred to as the Tetragrammaton or Shem HaMeforash (the Explicit Name), occupies a central position in Ma'avar Yabok's mystical system. This name is considered the most sacred in Jewish tradition, representing God's essential nature and serving as the primary channel for divine influence in the world. Throughout Ma'avar Yabok, the Tetragrammaton appears in various contexts related to death rituals, with multiple functions depending on its vowelization, combinations, and the specific intention (*kavvanah*) accompanying its contemplation.

Aaron Berechia presents the Tetragrammaton as corresponding primarily to the divine attribute of mercy (*rachamim*), in contrast to divine names associated with judgment (particularly Elohim). This polarity between mercy and judgment forms a crucial theological framework for understanding death in Ma'avar Yabok. The text consistently presents death-related rituals as opportunities to "sweeten judgments" (*mituk ha-dinim*), transforming the potentially harsh experience of death into a merciful transition. The Tetragrammaton serves as the primary instrument for this transformation.

The letters of the Tetragrammaton are associated with different aspects of divinity within the kabbalistic system of the ten sefirot (divine emanations). The first letter, Yod (י), corresponds to Chokhmah (Wisdom); the first Heh (ה) to Binah (Understanding); the Vav (ו) to the six middot (emotional attributes) from Chesed to Yesod; and the final Heh (ה) to Malkhut (Kingdom). This correspondence system allows the Tetragrammaton to function as a comprehensive channel connecting all levels of divine reality.

In Ma'avar Yabok, the Tetragrammaton appears with various vowelizations, each serving a specific metaphysical function. The text refers to "YHVH with the segol vowel points" (*havayah nekudah segol*), "YHVH with sheva vowel pointing" (*havayah nekudah sheva*), and "YHVH with the cholam vowel pointing" (*havayah nekudah cholam*). Each vowelization activates different spiritual channels, directing divine influence to specific cosmic realms and aspects of the soul.

One of the most significant applications of the Tetragrammaton in Ma'avar Yabok involves the 112 biblical verses recommended for recitation at the time of death. Of these, exactly 26 verses correspond to the Tetragrammaton, with 26 being the numerical value (gematria) of YHVH. These verses form part of a carefully structured mystical system designed to facilitate the soul's transition. According to Aaron Berechia, proper recitation of these verses with the correct intention regard-

ing the divine name creates a spiritual vehicle for the soul's ascent through cosmic realms.

The text also describes specific meditations on the Tetragrammaton for those attending a dying person. During these critical moments, contemplation of the divine name with proper intention is believed to shield the departing soul from negative forces while opening channels of divine mercy. Aaron Berechia instructs that when death is imminent, those present should focus on unifying the Tetragrammaton with other divine names, particularly Adonai, creating a comprehensive spiritual protection.

The Tetragrammaton also features prominently in Ma'avar Yabok's treatment of the Shema prayer as a deathbed practice. Following Rabbi Akiva's example of reciting the Shema at his martyrdom, the dying person is encouraged to recite or contemplate this prayer with specific attention to the divine unifications it contains. The declaration "YHVH is One" is understood as facilitating what the text calls "death by divine kiss" (*mittat neshikah*), considered the most elevated form of death where the soul departs in mystical union with the divine.

Furthermore, Ma'avar Yabok presents various expansions of the Tetragrammaton, including "the divine name YHVH spelled fully with Yuds" and other alphanumeric formulations. These expansions serve to amplify specific aspects of divine influence, creating more specialized channels for divine mercy during the death process. The text also references combinations of the Tetragrammaton with other divine names, particularly "YHVH and ADNY interwoven" (*havayah ve-adnut meshulabim*), which represents the mystical union of masculine and feminine divine principles considered essential for cosmic harmony.

Through these varied applications, the Tetragrammaton emerges in Ma'avar Yabok as the primary divine name for facilitating the soul's peaceful transition at death. Its fundamental association with mercy serves to counterbalance the judgment inherent in the death process, while its connections to all levels of divine reality enable it to guide the soul through the various spiritual realms it must traverse after departing from the body.

Adonai (ADNY): the divine feminine and judgment

The divine name Adonai (אד״נ״י), often represented in kabbalistic texts with its Hebrew letters Alef-Dalet-Nun-Yod, holds a special place in Ma'avar Yabok's mystical system. While in standard Jewish practice Adonai serves as the vocalized substitute for the ineffable Tetragrammaton, in kabbalistic thought it represents a distinct divine aspect with its own metaphysical properties. Throughout Ma'avar Yabok, Adonai is consistently associated with Malkhut (Kingdom), the tenth and lowest sefirah, which represents the divine feminine principle often referred to as the Shekhinah (Divine Presence).

In Aaron Berechia's kabbalistic framework, Adonai embodies the attribute of judgment (din) and governs the realm that the soul must first navigate after death. The text refers to this realm as the "feminine world" (*alma de-nukba*), contrasting it with the "masculine world" (*alma de-dekhura*) associated with the Tetragrammaton and higher spiritual realms. This gendered cosmic structure informs many of the ritual practices described in Ma'avar Yabok, particularly those designed to elevate

the soul beyond the initial stage of judgment represented by Adonai.

The gematria (numerical value) of Adonai is 65, which explains why exactly 65 verses are included in the collection of 112 biblical verses to be recited at the time of death. These 65 verses specifically correspond to Adonai and are intended to address the soul's passage through the realm of judgment. According to Ma'avar Yabok, proper recitation of these verses with the correct intention regarding Adonai helps mitigate harsh judgments and facilitates the soul's elevation to higher realms.

A central concept in Ma'avar Yabok is the need to "sweeten judgments" (*mituk ha-dinim* or *bisum ha-din*), transforming the potentially harsh experience of divine judgment into a merciful process. This transformation is often achieved through the mystical unification of Adonai with the Tetragrammaton, representing the union of feminine and masculine divine principles, judgment and mercy. The text frequently refers to "YHVH and ADNY" (*havayah ve-adnut*) as paired divine names that need to be unified through proper ritual intentions.

One particularly significant formulation in Ma'avar Yabok is "YHVH and ADNY interwoven" (*havayah ve-adnut meshulabim*), describing a specific contemplative practice where the letters of these two divine names are mentally intertwined to create a unified channel of divine influence. This practice is recommended at various points in the death ritual, particularly when reciting the Shema prayer and during the tahara (ritual washing of the deceased).

In burial prayers, Adonai features prominently as the divine name most directly connected to the physical body and its return to earth. The text explains that the body derives from the realm of Malkhut/Adonai, while higher soul components connect to other divine names and sefirot. Funeral prayers therefore often invoke Adonai to facilitate the proper reintegration of the body with its source, while simultaneously calling upon other divine names to guide the soul's ascent.

Ma'avar Yabok also refers to Adonai as "Tzedek, the lower Mother" (*Tzedek ima tata'ah*), highlighting its connection to both justice (tzedek) and the feminine divine principle. This designation emphasizes Adonai's role in receiving and judging souls as they depart from the physical world. The text explains that proper ritual actions and intentions can transform this judgment into a form of purification that prepares the soul for higher spiritual realms.

During the seven days of mourning (shiva), Ma'avar Yabok prescribes specific prayers and meditations focused on Adonai, helping to guide the soul through what the text describes as seven celestial chambers or palaces (*heikhalot*) within the realm of Malkhut. These chambers represent progressive stages of the soul's purification after death, with the divine name Adonai serving as both gateway and guide through this initial phase of the afterlife journey.

The mourning rituals themselves are explained as creating cosmic effects within the realm of Adonai/Malkhut, with each ritual action below having a corresponding impact above. This metaphysical correspondence between human action and divine response forms a central principle in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to death rituals, with Adonai serving as the primary channel through which this correspondence operates.

Through these various functions, Adonai emerges in Ma'avar Yabok as a divine name of profound significance for death rituals, representing both the challenges the soul faces in its initial post-mortem state and the means through which these challenges can be transformed into opportunities for spiritual elevation.

Ehyeh (אהיה): divine becoming and soul elevation

The divine name Ehyeh (אהיה), meaning "I Will Be" or "I Am That I Am," appears in Ma'avar Yabok as a powerful mystical name particularly relevant to the soul's elevation after death. This name, first revealed to Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3:14), represents divine becoming and potentiality within Aaron Berechia's kabbalistic system. Throughout the text, Ehyeh is associated with Binah (Understanding), the third sefirah, which functions as the supernal source of souls and the ultimate destination for their return after death.

Ma'avar Yabok refers to Ehyeh as connected to the "supernal Mother" (*Ima Ila'ah*) or "supernal Eden" (*Eden Ila'ah*), portraying it as the divine aspect that initially emanates souls and ultimately receives them back after their journey through lower realms. This cyclic process of emanation and return provides the metaphysical framework for understanding death as a form of spiritual homecoming rather than an ending.

The gematria of Ehyeh is 21, which explains why exactly 21 biblical verses from the collection of 112 verses for the dying correspond specifically to this divine name. These verses are described as creating a channel for the soul's ascent to the highest realms associated with Binah/Ehyeh. According to Aaron Berechia, proper recitation of these verses with the correct intention facilitates what the text calls "death by divine kiss" (*mittat neshikah*), the most elevated form of death reserved for the righteous.

In Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed rituals, Ehyeh features prominently in prayers designed to release the soul from its attachment to the body. The text instructs those attending the dying to meditate on Ehyeh with specific vowelizations that activate its potential to draw the soul upward. This practice is described as creating a "supernal attraction" that gently separates the soul from physical existence while minimizing suffering.

The divine name Ehyeh also appears in Ma'avar Yabok's instructions for tahara (ritual washing of the deceased). During this ritual, contemplation of Ehyeh while pouring water over specific body parts is said to facilitate the elevation of corresponding soul aspects to their source in Binah. The text prescribes a precise sequence of washings, each accompanied by biblical verses and intentions focused on different divine names, with Ehyeh featured prominently when addressing the higher soul components.

Ma'avar Yabok discusses the mystical significance of Ehyeh in relation to the afterlife journey, describing how this divine name opens what the text calls the "concealed channel from Keter to Binah" (*tzinor ha-ne'elam mi-Keter le-Binah*). This metaphysical pathway represents the highest route of ascent for the soul, bypassing lower realms of judgment and allowing direct access to the supernal source. According to Aaron Berechia, this channel opens fully on Yom Kippur, which explains the special efficacy of prayers for the dead on this holy day.

The text also discusses combinations of Ehyeh with other divine names, particularly "YHVH and Ehyeh" (*havayah ve-ehyeh*), representing the mystical union of Binah (Understanding) and the six emotional attributes governed by the Tetragrammaton. This combination is described as particularly powerful for elevating the soul beyond the realm of judgment and into the "supernal delight" (*oneg ha-elyon*) associated with Binah.

Aaron Berechia explains that the threefold repetition of the confession formula "I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled" (*chatati, aviti, pashati*) corresponds to the three letters of Ehyeh, creating a mystical alignment that transforms confession into a vehicle for the soul's ascent to Binah. This exemplifies the text's consistent approach of finding correspondences between ritual actions and divine names to create cosmic effects.

For those who have achieved high spiritual levels during life, Ma'avar Yabok describes a direct connection between their souls and the divine name Ehyeh. These elevated souls are said to bypass lower judgments entirely, ascending directly to what the text calls the "supernal whiteness" (*loven ha-elyon*) associated with Ehyeh. This concept provides consolation by suggesting that the righteous experience death not as judgment but as immediate spiritual elevation.

Through these various functions, Ehyeh emerges in Ma'avar Yabok as a divine name particularly concerned with the soul's ultimate destination and highest potential. While Adonai governs the initial phase of the afterlife journey and the Tetragrammaton mediates between judgment and mercy, Ehyeh represents the final ascent to the soul's divine source—the culmination of the spiritual process that begins at death.

The 42-letter divine name (Shem Mem-Bet)

The 42-letter Divine Name, referred to in Ma'avar Yabok as "Shem Mem-Bet" (שם מ״ב), represents one of the most powerful mystical formulations in Jewish esoteric tradition. This name receives extensive treatment in Aaron Berechia's text, with multiple chapters dedicated to its structure, origins, cosmic organization, and specific applications in death rituals. Unlike the Tetragrammaton or Adonai, the 42-letter Name is not a single word but a complex sequence of letters divided into seven groups of six letters each, often represented by their initial letters or through acrostics.

The first group of letters, "ABGITATZ" (אבגיתץ״), is frequently mentioned in Ma'avar Yabok as shorthand for the entire name. The text also refers to the last group, "SHAKUTZIT" (שקוצי״ת), creating a symbolic representation of the complete 42-letter sequence. According to kabbalistic tradition, this name derives from the first 42 letters of the creation narrative in Genesis, or alternatively, from permutations of the Tetragrammaton, though Aaron Berechia does not explicitly commit to either origin theory.

In Ma'avar Yabok, the 42-letter Name serves primarily as a protective force during the soul's vulnerable transition at death. The text describes this name as creating a metaphysical shield that prevents negative spiritual entities (referred to as "external forces" or *chitzonim*) from interfering with the soul's journey. Aaron Berechia provides detailed instructions for how attendants at a deathbed should meditate on this name, visualizing it as surrounding the dying person in letters of light.

The ritual of seven circuits (*hakafot*) around the deceased's bier before burial is directly connected to the seven groups of the 42-letter Name in Ma'avar Yabok. Each circuit corresponds to one group of six letters, with specific prayers structured around these letters to be recited during each circuit. This practice is described as

creating a sevenfold protection that accompanies the soul through its initial post-mortem journey while simultaneously driving away harmful spiritual forces.

The text associates each of the seven groups with a specific sefirah, creating a comprehensive system of correspondences that maps the 42-letter Name onto the kabbalistic Tree of Life. The first group corresponds to Chesed (Loving-kindness), the second to Gevurah (Strength), the third to Tiferet (Beauty), and so on through all seven lower sefirot. This correspondence system enables the name to function as a channel connecting all levels of divine reality, making it particularly effective for guiding the soul through various cosmic realms.

Ma'avar Yabok contains specific instructions for visualizing the 42-letter Name during the recitation of Isaiah's throne vision (Chapter 6:1-3), which the text recommends as a key practice when death is imminent. This visualization involves complex mental arrangements of letters, combined with specific breathing techniques and physical gestures like raising the hands. According to Aaron Berechia, this practice facilitates what he calls "the elevation of divine sparks" (*ha'ala'at nitzotzot*), a concept derived from Lurianic Kabbalah referring to the liberation of divine light trapped in material existence.

The 42-letter Name also features prominently in protective prayers recited after death to shield the soul during its initial vulnerable state. The text presents formulations like "Ana Bekoach" (אנא בכח), a prayer containing 42 words that serve as a vessel for the power of the 42-letter Name. This prayer appears specifically in the context of deathbed rituals, where it is to be recited to facilitate the soul's peaceful transition.

Aaron Berechia explains that the numerical value 42 has special significance because it represents the mystical "42 journeys" of the Israelites in the wilderness, which serve as a metaphor for the soul's journey after death. Just as the Israelites traveled through 42 stations before reaching the Promised Land, the soul traverses 42 spiritual stages before reaching its divine destination. The 42-letter Name thus functions as both map and passport for this metaphysical journey.

The text provides detailed instructions for various deathbed practices involving the 42-letter Name, including specific visualizations of the name in different colors and configurations depending on the condition of the dying person. These practices are described as capable of transforming even difficult deaths into peaceful transitions, demonstrating the name's power to override negative judgments and spiritual obstacles.

In the context of tahara (ritual washing of the deceased), Ma'avar Yabok prescribes meditations on the 42-letter Name while pouring water over the body. This practice is said to cleanse not only the physical remains but also the "garment of the soul" (*levush ha-nefesh*), a subtle energetic envelope that accompanies the soul after death. The 42 letters correspond to 42 channels of purification that restore the soul's original luminosity.

Through these varied applications, the 42-letter Divine Name emerges in Ma'avar Yabok as a comprehensive spiritual technology for managing the complex transition of death. Its extensive treatment in the text reflects Aaron Berechia's commitment to providing practical mystical guidance for this critical spiritual passage, combining protective, elevating, and transformative functions in a single powerful formulation.

The 72-letter divine name (Shem Ayin-Bet)

The 72-letter Divine Name, referred to in Ma'avar Yabok as "Shem Ayin-Bet" (שם ע״ב), represents another powerful mystical formulation with specific applications in death rituals. This name consists of 72 three-letter combinations derived from three verses in Exodus (14:19-21), each containing exactly 72 letters. When these verses are arranged in a specific pattern (the first verse written forward, the second backward, and the third forward), they yield 72 three-letter sequences that collectively form this extended divine name.

In Ma'avar Yabok, the 72-letter Name is primarily associated with angelic forces that guide and protect the soul during its post-mortem journey. Aaron Berechia describes this name as creating what he calls "72 bridges of kindness" (*ayin-bet gishrei ha-chesed*), metaphysical pathways that allow the soul to safely traverse potentially dangerous spiritual territories. These bridges connect different cosmic realms, providing the soul with secure passage through the complex metaphysical landscape it encounters after death.

The text associates the 72-letter Name with Chesed (Loving-kindness), the fourth sefirah, positioning it as a powerful force for mitigating judgments and attracting divine mercy. Unlike the 42-letter Name, which functions primarily as protection against external forces, the 72-letter Name actively transforms the spiritual environment, creating what Aaron Berechia calls "illuminated pathways" (*netivin de-nehirin*) through otherwise darkened realms.

Ma'avar Yabok presents specific applications of the 72-letter Name in protective prayers for the dying, particularly recommending its use when the dying person appears to be struggling with the departure of the soul. The text explains that each three-letter sequence within the name corresponds to a specific angelic force that can assist with different aspects of the death transition. These angels are described as "escorts" (*melavin*) who guide the soul safely through the initial stages of its journey.

Aaron Berechia provides instructions for visualizing the 72 three-letter sequences arranged in specific geometric patterns around the dying person. These visualizations, combined with whispered recitations of the corresponding angel names, are said to create a protective shield that prevents harmful spiritual entities from interfering with the soul's departure. The text emphasizes that these practices should be performed discreetly, without disturbing the dying person's concentration.

The 72-letter Name also features in Ma'avar Yabok's instructions for tahara (ritual washing of the deceased). The text recommends that those performing this ritual mentally divide the body into 72 segments, each corresponding to one three-letter sequence of the name. As water is poured over each segment, the corresponding angel is invoked to purify and protect that aspect of the deceased's being. This practice is described as ensuring that all components of the person's spiritual structure receive proper attention during the purification process.

During the funeral procession, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes meditations on the 72-letter Name as a means of creating what the text calls a "celestial escort" (*livuy shel ma'alah*) that accompanies the soul. This escort is described as consisting of 72 angelic beings who form a protective entourage around the soul, shielding it from accusers and guiding it toward its proper place in the afterlife realms.

The text associates specific three-letter sequences from the 72-letter Name with

particular transitions in the afterlife journey. For example, the sequence מה״ש (MHS) is described as assisting the soul's passage through what Aaron Berechia calls the "River of Fire" (*nehar dinur*), a metaphysical barrier that souls must cross after death. Other sequences correspond to entrance points for different chambers or palaces (*heikhalot*) that the soul must navigate.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that the 72-letter Name has special efficacy for elevating the soul because it connects to what the text calls the "World of Mercy" (*alma de-rachamei*), a cosmic domain where harsh judgments cannot penetrate. By invoking this name with proper intention, those conducting death rituals can help ensure that the deceased's soul bypasses or minimizes exposure to judgmental forces, experiencing instead a direct elevation to realms of divine benevolence.

The text also discusses how the 72-letter Name interacts with the three primary components of the soul: Nefesh, Ruach, and Neshamah. According to Aaron Berechia, each component requires different aspects of the name to guide its specific journey. The Nefesh, which remains closest to the physical world, is assisted by the first 24 three-letter sequences; the Ruach, which ascends to intermediate realms, by the middle 24; and the Neshamah, which reaches the highest realms, by the final 24 sequences.

Through these various applications, the 72-letter Divine Name functions in Ma'avar Yabok as a comprehensive system for managing the soul's cosmic ascent after death. While other divine names address specific aspects of the death process, the 72-letter Name provides a complete metaphysical infrastructure for the soul's journey, combining protective, guiding, and elevating functions through its connection to angelic forces and pathways of divine mercy.

Unification of divine names: cosmic integration

A fundamental principle in Ma'avar Yabok's mystical system is the unification (*yichud*) of divine names to create powerful spiritual effects during death rituals. Rather than treating divine names as isolated forces, Aaron Berechia consistently emphasizes their integration and interaction, presenting death rituals as opportunities to facilitate cosmic unifications that benefit both the deceased and the broader spiritual universe.

The most frequently mentioned unification involves the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) and Adonai (ADNY), represented in the text as "YHVH and ADNY" (*havayah ve-adnut*). This pairing symbolizes the union of divine masculine and feminine principles, or more specifically, the harmonization of mercy (represented by YHVH) and judgment (represented by Adonai). Aaron Berechia describes this unification as creating a balanced channel for the soul's transition, ensuring that it experiences neither excessive severity nor undisciplined compassion.

Ma'avar Yabok presents several methods for achieving this unification, including the formula "YHVH and ADNY interwoven" (*havayah ve-adnut meshulabim*). This practice involves mentally interweaving the letters of these two names to create a unified channel of divine influence. The text explains that this interweaving mirrors a cosmic process occurring in higher realms when the unification is properly executed, creating what Aaron Berechia calls "supernal unions" (*zivugim ila'in*) that facilitate the soul's ascent.

Another significant unification involves the divine names YHVH and Ehyeh, represented as "Havayah and Ehyeh" (*havayah ve-ehyeh*). This combination connects the realms of Tiferet (associated with YHVH) and Binah (associated with Ehyeh), creating a direct channel for the soul's elevation to higher spiritual dimensions. Aaron Berechia recommends this unification particularly during the recitation of the Shema at the moment of death, describing it as facilitating the mystical experience of "death by divine kiss" (*mittat neshikah*).

The text also discusses unifications involving all three primary divine names—YHVH, Adonai, and Ehyeh—noting that their combined numerical value equals 112, which is also the gematria of Yabok (יב״ק). This numerical correspondence explains why Ma'avar Yabok prescribes exactly 112 biblical verses for recitation at the time of death: 21 corresponding to Ehyeh, 26 to YHVH, and 65 to Adonai. According to Aaron Berechia, proper recitation of these verses with the correct intentions regarding the corresponding divine names creates a comprehensive unification that addresses all aspects of the soul's journey.

More complex unifications involve combining the explicit divine names with expanded formulations and permutations. Ma'avar Yabok discusses practices such as meditating on "the divine name YHVH spelled fully with Yuds" and various other alphanumeric expansions. These expanded formulations serve to amplify specific aspects of divine influence, creating specialized channels for different components of the soul during their distinct journeys through the afterlife realms.

The text presents specific visualizations for achieving divine name unifications at critical moments in the death process. For example, Aaron Berechia instructs that when death is imminent, those present should visualize the letters of the Tetragrammaton surrounded by the letters of Adonai, creating a protective shield around the departing soul. This visualization is accompanied by whispered recitations of biblical verses that contain these divine names, establishing a rhythm that guides the soul's exit from the body.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that divine name unifications have particular potency during death rituals because the boundary between physical and spiritual realms temporarily dissolves at this transition point. The text describes death as creating an "opening of gates" (*petichat she'arim*) that allows more direct access to higher spiritual dimensions. Divine name unifications serve to structure and direct the energies flowing through these open gates, ensuring they benefit rather than overwhelm the departing soul.

The concept of "sweetening judgments" (*mituk ha-dinim*) features prominently in discussions of divine name unifications. Aaron Berechia explains that the proper integration of divine names transforms what might otherwise be experienced as harsh judgment into a process of purification and elevation. This transformation is described as occurring through the mystical mechanism of redirecting divine energies from the "left side" (associated with judgment) to the "right side" (associated with mercy).

Beyond their effect on the individual soul, divine name unifications in death rituals are presented as having cosmic significance. Aaron Berechia explains that these practices contribute to what he calls "rectification of the upper realms" (*tikkun ha-olamot ha-elyonim*), helping to restore cosmic harmony disrupted by various metaphysical factors. Death rituals thus become opportunities for tikkun olam (world-repair) in its most profound sense, with each properly conducted ritual con-

tributing to universal spiritual restoration.

The text emphasizes that divine name unifications must be performed with proper kavvanah (intention), requiring both intellectual understanding and emotional alignment. Those performing death rituals are instructed to cultivate specific mental and emotional states corresponding to different divine names and their unifications. For example, meditations on YHVH should evoke compassion and expansiveness, while meditations on Adonai should evoke reverence and containment. The proper balance and integration of these states creates the ideal condition for effective divine name unification.

Through these various practices, the unification of divine names emerges in Ma'avar Yabok as both the method and goal of death rituals—the means through which the soul navigates its transition and the cosmic result of properly conducted rituals. This dual function highlights Aaron Berechia's view of death not merely as an individual passage but as an opportunity for universal spiritual harmonization.

Divine names as cosmic technology

In Ma'avar Yabok, divine names function as a sophisticated cosmic technology for navigating the complex transition of death. Aaron Berechia presents these names not merely as designations for God but as active channels of divine influence that can be precisely applied to facilitate the soul's journey. This approach transforms death rituals from mere customs into spiritual techniques with profound metaphysical effects.

The system of divine names in Ma'avar Yabok reflects a comprehensive kabbalistic worldview in which the boundaries between physical and spiritual realms are permeable, particularly at moments of transition like death. Divine names serve as the primary means for managing this permeability, allowing controlled interactions between realms while maintaining necessary protections and boundaries.

Aaron Berechia's treatment of divine names demonstrates the integration of earlier kabbalistic traditions—particularly those deriving from the Zohar and Lurianic Kabbalah—into a practical manual for religious practitioners. Rather than presenting these traditions as abstract theological concepts, Ma'avar Yabok translates them into specific ritual actions with clear instructions regarding the application of divine names at each stage of the death process.

The text consistently emphasizes that proper intention (*kavvanah*) is essential when working with divine names. It is not enough to mechanically recite or visualize these names; one must understand their significance and cultivate the appropriate spiritual state corresponding to each name. This requirement transforms death rituals into opportunities for deep spiritual practice not only for the dying but also for those attending them.

The metaphysical framework underlying Ma'avar Yabok's system of divine names presents death as a transition rather than an ending—a passage from one state of being to another that requires proper navigation. Divine names serve as both map and vehicle for this navigation, guiding the soul through various spiritual territories while protecting it from potential dangers along the way.

For modern readers, the elaborate system of divine names in Ma'avar Yabok may seem distant from contemporary approaches to death and dying. However,

this system addresses universal human concerns about the meaning of death, the fate of consciousness, and the possibility of continued existence beyond physical dissolution. Through its sophisticated application of divine names, Ma'avar Yabok offers a response to these concerns that affirms both the reality of death and the possibility of transcendence.

Moreover, the text's emphasis on community involvement in death rituals, facilitated through the shared contemplation of divine names, provides a model for addressing death not as an isolated individual experience but as a communal transition with cosmic significance. This approach contrasts sharply with modern tendencies to isolate and medicalize death, offering instead a vision of death integrated into the spiritual life of the community.

While few contemporary readers may engage with divine names in the precise manner prescribed by Ma'avar Yabok, understanding this system provides valuable insight into Jewish mystical approaches to death and reveals the profound spiritual resources that traditional practices can offer for confronting mortality. The elaborate correspondences between divine names, cosmic realms, and soul components present death not as a chaotic rupture but as a structured transition within a meaningful spiritual cosmos.

In the final analysis, Ma'avar Yabok's system of divine names represents one of the most sophisticated attempts in Jewish tradition to address the ultimate human transition through a combination of mystical insight and practical ritual. Its comprehensive integration of divine names into every aspect of death rituals demonstrates a commitment to honoring this transition with the full resources of Jewish spiritual tradition, transforming death from a merely biological event into a meaningful spiritual passage.

Appendix E

Deathbed practices and the vidui (confession) ritual

Within the rich tapestry of Jewish religious life, few moments hold as much spiritual gravity as the transition from life to death. While contemporary Western culture often regards death as a topic to be avoided or sanitized, the Jewish tradition has developed a sophisticated framework for approaching death that acknowledges its inevitability while infusing it with profound spiritual meaning. Ma'avar Yabok, the seventeenth-century handbook authored by Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena, stands as perhaps the most comprehensive guide to these practices, integrating practical ritual instruction with kabbalistic interpretation to create a holistic approach to the final moments of life.

The very title of the work—"The Crossing of the Jabbok"—provides a powerful metaphorical framework for understanding the Jewish conception of death. The reference is to the biblical narrative of Jacob, who crossed the Jabbok River before his transformative encounter with an angel (Genesis 32). Just as Jacob's crossing marked a moment of profound spiritual transition, so too does death represent not an ending but a crossing over, a transition from one state of being to another. This conceptualization stands in stark contrast to views that regard death simply as cessation or annihilation.

Jewish tradition conceptualizes terminal illness not merely as biological failure but as a spiritual process with profound purpose. Ma'avar Yabok presents illness as "divine correction" and an opportunity for spiritual purification. Rather than viewing suffering as random misfortune or punishment, Aaron Berechia frames it within a comprehensive theological system where physical decline serves a spiritual purpose. As he explains, God communicates through progressive physical ailments as warnings, providing opportunities for repentance and spiritual preparation before death.

This perspective may seem foreign to modern sensibilities, which often frame illness in purely mechanistic terms. However, it offers an important alternative that many find meaningful even today—the possibility that suffering can have purpose and that proper preparation for death is a sacred obligation rather than a surrender to the inevitable. The rituals surrounding the deathbed that will be explored in this

appendix represent the practical manifestation of this theological framework, offering structure and meaning during what could otherwise be a chaotic and frightening time.

The Jewish approach to terminal illness and death stands on two pillars that might initially seem contradictory: unflinching acknowledgment of death's reality coupled with unwavering affirmation of life's sanctity. On one hand, Judaism rejects any notion of hiding the reality of impending death from the dying person; on the other, it maintains that until the final moment, life must be preserved and valued. This tension creates a unique ritual approach that balances pragmatic preparation for death with an attitude that regards each remaining moment as precious.

Within this conceptual framework, Ma'avar Yabok outlines specific rituals for those approaching death. These practices are not mere formalities but represent a sophisticated spiritual technology designed to assist the soul in its transition. The deathbed rituals combine biblical verses, prayers, confessional formulas, and specific physical actions that collectively create what might be understood as a sacred choreography for the final moments of life. For the dying person, these rituals provide structure and meaning; for those in attendance, they offer a way to be genuinely helpful at a moment when one might otherwise feel helpless.

Central to these practices is the concept that proper spiritual preparation can influence one's experience in the afterlife. While contemporary Judaism often downplays discussions of the afterlife (olam ha-ba), Ma'avar Yabok—influenced by kabbalistic thought—provides an elaborate conception of what awaits the soul after death. The rituals performed at the deathbed are understood to directly affect the soul's journey, potentially easing its passage through judgment and toward divine presence. This understanding provides added urgency and significance to ensuring that death occurs within a proper ritual framework.

The ethical obligation to inform the dying

One of the most striking aspects of Ma'avar Yabok's approach to terminal illness is its insistence on truth-telling, albeit with appropriate sensitivity. While modern medical ethics continues to debate whether and how to inform patients of terminal diagnoses, the Jewish tradition as articulated by Aaron Berechia takes a clear position: the dying person should be made aware of their condition to enable proper spiritual preparation.

Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that approaching death should be communicated truthfully but gently to the dying person, contrasting with harmful practices of false reassurance. The text states that "one should not give false hope to the ill person, telling him that he will recover when one sees that he is on the verge of death." This approach reflects the view that concealing the truth about one's condition deprives the individual of the opportunity to engage in essential spiritual preparation, particularly confession (vidui) and reconciliation with others.

However, this truth-telling comes with important qualifications. The information should be conveyed with sensitivity and compassion, never bluntly or harshly. Moreover, it should be presented within a framework that offers spiritual purpose and meaning rather than simply delivering the cold facts of medical prognosis. Ma'avar Yabok recommends a gradual approach, where someone close to the

patient—not a physician—gently suggests that they put their affairs in order and prepare spiritually, just as all must eventually do.

The ethical framework underlying this approach values autonomy and dignity. By informing individuals of their condition, they regain a measure of control at a time when much seems beyond their control. They can choose how to spend their remaining time, with whom to reconcile, and how to prepare spiritually. In this way, the truth serves not to diminish hope but to redirect it from unrealistic expectations of physical recovery to spiritual preparation and meaningful closure.

This approach stands in notable contrast to practices common in many cultures, where terminal diagnoses may be concealed from patients while being disclosed to family members. Such practices often assume that knowledge of impending death would cause unbearable anguish or that patients would "give up" if informed. The Jewish tradition as articulated in Ma'avar Yabok takes a different view—that knowledge of one's condition, when properly framed, can be empowering rather than demoralizing.

The text also warns against the opposite extreme—creating unnecessary anxiety by suggesting that death is imminent when it may not be. Baseless predictions of impending death are considered harmful and prohibited. The goal is accurate, compassionate communication that serves the dying person's spiritual needs, not dramatization or unnecessary distress.

This balanced approach to truth-telling reflects Judaism's broader ethical stance that values truth (emet) as a divine attribute while also recognizing that how truth is communicated matters deeply. The objective is not merely factual accuracy but wisdom in how information is conveyed, always with the well-being of the recipient as the guiding principle.

The concept of a 'good death' in Jewish tradition

The idea of a "good death" (mitah yafah) appears throughout rabbinic literature and is elaborated in Ma'avar Yabok. Far from simply indicating a painless physical end, this concept encompasses a complex set of spiritual, emotional, and communal elements that together constitute the ideal transition from life to death according to Jewish tradition.

Central to the Jewish conception of a good death is the element of conscious preparation. Unlike traditions that might valorize sudden death as sparing suffering, Jewish thought generally regards unexpected death as less than ideal because it deprives the individual of the opportunity for final spiritual preparations. Ma'avar Yabok frames death as a spiritual birth, contrasting physical birth (birth of the body) with death (birth of the soul). Just as physical birth requires preparation, so too does this spiritual birth demand mindful attention and specific rituals.

A good death in the Jewish tradition is one that occurs with full consciousness and in a state of spiritual readiness. Ideally, the dying person has reconciled with others, settled worldly affairs, offered ethical guidance to descendants, and most importantly, made peace with God through confession (vidui). The traditional deathbed confession is not merely an acknowledgment of wrongdoing but a comprehensive spiritual closure that includes expressions of faith, acceptance of divine judgment, and surrender of the soul to its Creator.

Ma'avar Yabok also emphasizes the communal dimension of a good death. Death should not occur in isolation but in the presence of the community, represented by a minyan (quorum of ten Jews). This presence serves multiple functions: it provides comfort to the dying, creates a sacred space where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) is believed to dwell, and forms a protective spiritual barrier that aids the soul's transition. The text uses the biblical concept of "Mahanaim" (two camps) to describe how at death, the human realm (represented by ten Jews) meets the angelic realm, creating a protected pathway for the soul's ascent.

Physical elements also factor into the Jewish conception of a good death. Ideally, death occurs in a state of ritual purity, with the body positioned properly (lying flat rather than upright), and with nothing impeding the soul's departure. Ma'avar Yabok provides detailed instructions about removing pillows, placing the dying person on the ground (symbolizing return to the earth), and ensuring that nothing (like salt or metal) that might attract harmful spiritual forces is present.

Perhaps most distinctively, a good death in Jewish tradition is characterized by specific verbal formulations. The recitation of the Shema prayer at the moment of death is considered especially powerful, following the example of Rabbi Akiva, who recited it during his martyrdom. The declaration "Into Your hand I commit my spirit" (Psalm 31:6) is also prescribed for the final moments. These verbal elements are understood as not merely symbolic but efficacious, actively facilitating the soul's transition.

The kabbalistic concept of "death by divine kiss" (mitat neshikah) represents the highest form of good death in Ma'avar Yabok. This metaphor describes a death that occurs through mystical union with the divine rather than through the agency of the Angel of Death. While traditionally reserved for the most righteous individuals like Moses, the text suggests that proper spiritual preparation can help anyone approach this elevated form of departure, where the soul is received directly by God rather than being subjected to the harsher processes of judgment.

Ma'avar Yabok frames a good death not as the absence of suffering but as its transformation into spiritual elevation. Physical suffering is understood to weaken negative spiritual forces (kelipot/chitzonim) while strengthening the soul's dominance. The text employs a motif of the body as sacrifice, connecting physical suffering to Temple sacrificial rituals and positioning the righteous person's body as a direct offering to God. This conceptual framework provides meaning to what might otherwise seem like senseless suffering, integrating it into a larger spiritual narrative.

Ultimately, the concept of a good death in Jewish tradition as articulated in Ma'avar Yabok is less about the physical circumstances of dying and more about the spiritual state in which death occurs. A good death is one where the individual has achieved a measure of spiritual completion, has been reconciled with both God and community, and approaches death not as an ending but as a transition—a crossing of the Jabbok—into another form of existence.

The Minyan at the deathbed

Among the most distinctive features of Jewish deathbed practice is the gathering of a minyan—a quorum of ten Jewish adults—to accompany the dying person in

their final hours. Ma'avar Yabok places great emphasis on this practice, explaining it not merely as a comfort to the dying but as a spiritual necessity with profound mystical significance for the soul's journey.

The basic requirement stems from the principle that the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) dwells among a gathered community of ten. This concept derives from the rabbinic interpretation of Psalm 82:1, "God stands in the divine assembly," with "assembly" being understood to require a minimum of ten individuals. By ensuring that death occurs within such an assembly, one creates a sacred space where the Divine Presence itself receives the departing soul. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that this presence "precedes and arrives" at the bedside, establishing a direct divine encounter at the moment of transition.

However, the text goes beyond this fundamental understanding to elaborate a sophisticated kabbalistic framework for the minyan's function. The ten individuals collectively embody the ten sefirot (divine emanations), creating a complete cosmic structure that facilitates the soul's ascent through the spiritual worlds. Their presence serves to "sweeten" or mitigate harsh judgment, transforming what could be a difficult transition into one characterized more by divine mercy than severity.

Ma'avar Yabok employs the biblical concept of "Mahanaim" (two camps) from Genesis 32:1–2, where Jacob encounters angels, as a metaphor for what occurs at death. The text explains that the gathering of ten Jews creates a "human camp" that interfaces with the "angelic camp," establishing a protected corridor for the soul's journey. This dual encampment provides spiritual protection against harmful forces that might otherwise impede the soul's peaceful transition.

The minyan serves another crucial function according to the text: neutralizing spiritual accusers or prosecutors. In kabbalistic thought, a person's sins create negative spiritual entities that may serve as accusers in the heavenly court after death. The collective spiritual merit of the gathered minyan helps to counterbalance these accusations, providing a measure of protection for the departing soul. The text states that ten Jewish men (minyan) around the dying person creates a sacred space that drives away spiritual accusers and harmful forces through the power of their collective soul-sparks.

Not just any ten individuals constitute a proper deathbed minyan. Ideally, the text suggests, the gathering should include individuals of spiritual merit, particularly those well-versed in Torah. Their presence amplifies the protective and elevating effect. However, in the absence of such individuals, any Jewish adults fulfilling the requirements of a minyan will suffice, as the essential power derives from the divine promise to dwell among a community of ten regardless of their individual spiritual status.

The minyan is not passive during this time but actively engaged in specific ritual practices. They recite designated psalms, offer prayers on behalf of the dying, and assist with the confession ritual if necessary. During the final moments, they may recite the Shema in unison and, after death occurs, participate in the initial purification rituals. This active engagement creates a framework of continuous sacred action surrounding the dying person.

In practical terms, Ma'avar Yabok acknowledges that assembling a complete minyan may not always be possible, especially in cases of sudden death. In such instances, one should gather as many people as possible, with even a single knowledgeable individual being preferable to none. The text places such importance on

this practice that it permits violation of Sabbath restrictions to bring close relatives to a dying person's bedside, not only for the emotional comfort this provides but for the spiritual benefit to the departing soul.

The presence of the minyan continues to be important even after death occurs. The ten remain to recite specific prayers and psalms that guide the soul in its initial journey, to prevent harmful spiritual forces from approaching the body, and to begin the process of purification. The community that witnessed the death thus maintains a continuous sacred enclosure around both body and soul during the vulnerable initial phase of transition.

This practice reflects Judaism's fundamentally communal nature. Even in death—perhaps especially in death—the individual is not isolated but remains part of the community. The minyan's presence demonstrates that death is not a private affair but a communal transition, where the gathered community bears witness to and facilitates a fellow member's passage from one state of being to another.

The deathbed confession (Vidui)

At the center of Jewish deathbed practices stands the ritual of confession (vidui), a practice that Ma'avar Yabok describes as having profound spiritual significance beyond its apparent function. Far from being a mere acknowledgment of wrongdoing, the deathbed confession represents a comprehensive spiritual closure that prepares the soul for its transition through multiple spiritual realms.

The ritual's basic structure follows a pattern that has remained remarkably consistent through centuries of Jewish practice. It begins with an acknowledgment that one's death is in God's hands, continues with a confession of sins (often following an alphabetical acrostic pattern similar to the Yom Kippur liturgy), and concludes with an affirmation of faith in God and acceptance of divine judgment. The traditional formula includes the declaration: "I acknowledge before You, Lord my God and God of my ancestors, that my healing and my death are in Your hands. May it be Your will that You heal me with complete healing, but if I die, may my death be an atonement for all the sins, iniquities, and transgressions that I have committed before You."

Ma'avar Yabok provides multiple versions of the confession, ranging from elaborate formulations for those with sufficient time and mental clarity to abbreviated versions for emergency situations. The most complete form includes detailed enumeration of various categories of transgressions, organized according to their prescribed punishments in Jewish law—those warranting capital punishment, those requiring sin-offerings, those demanding guilt-offerings, and so forth. For each category, the confession acknowledges potential violations and seeks divine forgiveness.

The timing of the confession is crucial. The text emphasizes that confession should not be delayed until the final moments when consciousness may be impaired. Ideally, it should be recited while the dying person remains lucid and can participate fully in the ritual. However, the text is also practical, acknowledging that some may resist confession out of fear that it signifies giving up hope. In such cases, it suggests framing the confession as a precautionary measure that does not preclude the possibility of recovery, noting that even the healthiest individuals should confess daily.

According to Ma'avar Yabok, certain times are more spiritually auspicious for confession than others. Morning is considered particularly favorable due to the dominance of Chesed (divine kindness/mercy) at that time, making it more likely that repentance will be accepted. The text also explains the correspondence between days of the week and specific divine attributes (sefirot): Sunday corresponds to Chesed, Monday to Gevurah (strength/judgment), Tuesday to Tiferet (beauty/harmony), and so forth. These correspondences create a kabbalistic calendar that indicates optimal times for confession based on which divine attributes are ascendant.

The mystical dimensions of the confession ritual receive extensive treatment in Ma'avar Yabok. Drawing on kabbalistic sources, particularly the Zohar, the text explains that confession has profound effects across multiple spiritual worlds. It states that proper confession literally draws spiritual blemishes downward from higher realms and neutralizes Satan's ability to act as prosecutor in the divine court. It transforms the penitent from the "evil side" (sitra achra) to the "side of holiness," creating a metaphysical realignment of the soul with its divine source.

Aaron Berechia describes confession as having a threefold structure corresponding to the three most common terms for sin in Hebrew: chet (sin), avon (iniquity), and pesha (transgression). This tripartite division corresponds to damage in three divine attributes—Tiferet, Malkhut, and Yesod—which can be repaired through proper confession with specific mystical intentions. The text presents a detailed cosmological system where human confession creates cosmic repairs through a complex interplay of divine lights, desires, and emanations flowing through various levels from Keter (crown) down to the physical elements.

Ma'avar Yabok makes the remarkable claim that confession remains effective even when incomplete. The text states: "Even if one only recalls some of their sins during confession, all others are drawn along with them," providing comfort that perfect recall isn't necessary for complete repentance. This reflects a compassionate understanding of human limitations, particularly in the context of approaching death when full mental clarity may not be possible.

The physical circumstances of confession receive attention as well. The text recommends having a learned person act as an intermediary (sarsor) who recites the words for the dying person to repeat, comparing this to a prisoner who cannot free himself. This practical guidance acknowledges the physical limitations that may accompany terminal illness while ensuring that the ritual can still be properly performed.

For those too weak to recite the full confession, Ma'avar Yabok provides a drastically abbreviated form consisting of a single sentence: "May my death be an atonement for all my sins." In extreme cases, the text suggests that merely raising ten fingers toward heaven while thinking about divine unity constitutes a valid substitution for the verbal confession, demonstrating the tradition's flexibility in accommodating the realities of death.

Particularly notable is the text's emphasis on confession's continued efficacy even at the very threshold of death. It affirms that deathbed repentance is valid and effective, arguing that far from being insincere, repentance at the time of death can be especially genuine due to heightened spiritual awareness. Drawing on rabbinic sources, it assures readers that even someone who only contemplates repentance but dies before completing it can be rescued from negative spiritual realms by righteous souls who descend to retrieve them.

The gender dimensions of confession receive specific attention in Ma'avar Yabok. The text provides gender-specific confession guidance, with women specifically directed to focus on their three primary religious obligations: niddah (menstrual purity), challah separation, and candle-lighting. This reflects the gendered nature of religious obligations in traditional Judaism while ensuring that the confession ritual remains accessible and relevant to all.

Throughout its treatment of the confession ritual, Ma'avar Yabok balances technical kabbalistic exposition with profound psychological insight. The act of confession serves not only metaphysical purposes but provides psychological closure, allowing the dying person to review their life, acknowledge imperfections, and ultimately surrender to a process beyond their control. In this way, the ritual addresses both spiritual and emotional needs at a critical moment of transition.

The Shema at the moment of death

Among the various prayers and biblical verses recited at the deathbed, none holds greater significance than the Shema—Judaism's central declaration of faith proclaiming divine unity: "Hear, O Israel, the Lord is our God, the Lord is One." Ma'avar Yabok assigns special importance to this prayer during the final moments of life, explaining its profound mystical significance for the soul's transition.

The practice of reciting the Shema at death draws inspiration from the martyrdom of Rabbi Akiva, who, according to Talmudic tradition, recited this prayer as he was being executed by the Romans. The text presents Akiva's example as the ideal model for surrendering one's soul to God, noting that as he recited the final word "echad" (one), his soul departed with that declaration of divine unity on his lips. This historical precedent establishes the Shema as the quintessential deathbed prayer.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that the Shema is not merely a declaration of belief but a powerful mystical tool that creates cosmic unifications between different divine attributes and realms. When recited with proper intention (kavvanah), especially at the moment of death, it facilitates what the text calls "death by divine kiss" (mitat neshikah)—a spiritually elevated experience where the soul departs through direct divine reception rather than through the agency of the Angel of Death.

The kabbalistic dimensions of the Shema receive extensive treatment in the text. Drawing primarily on the Zohar, Aaron Berechia explains how each word and letter of the prayer corresponds to specific divine configurations and attributes. The six words of the first verse correlate to the six directions of space, while the first letter of the first word ('Shin' in "Shema") and the last letter of the last word ('Dalet' in "echad") together spell "shed" (demon). This teaches that proper recitation of the Shema with correct intention drives away harmful spiritual forces that might otherwise interfere with the soul's peaceful transition.

The final word of the first verse—"echad" (one)—receives particular attention. The tradition of elongating this word during recitation takes on special significance at death, as it represents the soul's final declaration of divine unity before departing. Ma'avar Yabok explains that the three letters of this word (alef, chet, dalet) correspond to different spiritual worlds and divine attributes. The numerical value of these letters ($1 + 8 + 4 = 13$) equals the Hebrew word for "love" (ahavah),

suggesting that the declaration of divine unity is simultaneously an expression of love for God—an appropriate final sentiment.

The text provides detailed instructions for those attending the dying regarding how to assist with the Shema recitation. If the dying person is capable, they should recite it themselves. If not, those present should recite it in their hearing, ideally close to their ear. The attendants are instructed to recite clearly but not too loudly, maintaining a reverential atmosphere. After the first verse, the traditional practice of quietly reciting "Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever" should be followed.

Ma'avar Yabok connects the Shema recitation to the concept of yichud (unification), explaining that through this prayer, the dying person participates in unifying divine masculine and feminine attributes (represented by the divine names YHVH and ADNY). This cosmic unification facilitates the soul's ascent through various spiritual worlds. The text states that through proper recitation with correct intention, one creates angels from each word that accompany the soul on its journey, offering protection and guidance.

The timing of the Shema recitation is crucial. Ideally, it should be said at the very moment when death appears imminent, but not so early that it must be repeated multiple times, which might diminish its spiritual power. The text advises close observation of the dying person's condition to determine the appropriate moment. Signs that death is imminent include changes in breathing patterns, facial coloration, and pulse, which those with experience attending the dying learn to recognize.

For kabbalistic practitioners, Ma'avar Yabok provides even more elaborate instructions regarding specific divine names and letter combinations to contemplate while reciting the Shema. These include visualizations of divine names with specific vowel patterns, meditations on the unity of the four-letter divine name (YHVH), and contemplation of how each component of the prayer affects different levels of the soul (nefesh, ruach, neshamah). While acknowledging that such advanced practices are not for everyone, the text suggests that even those without kabbalistic training can benefit from reciting the prayer with sincere devotion.

The Shema's effectiveness at the moment of death is explained through the concept of deveikut (cleaving to God). The text describes the final moments as an opportunity for the soul to achieve an elevated state of communion with the divine, where the boundaries between individual consciousness and divine reality begin to dissolve. The declaration of God's unity in the Shema mirrors and facilitates this spiritual unification of the soul with its divine source.

Ma'avar Yabok acknowledges that not every death allows for the ideal scenario of conscious Shema recitation. In cases of sudden death or unconsciousness, those present should still recite the prayer on behalf of the dying person. The text assures readers that the soul, even when the body appears unresponsive, often retains awareness of surroundings and can benefit from hearing the Shema even if unable to participate verbally.

This practice reflects Judaism's emphasis on conscious engagement with death rather than avoidance or denial. By framing the final moments of life as an opportunity for the ultimate affirmation of faith, the tradition transforms what could be a moment of fear or despair into one of profound spiritual significance and connection.

The 112 biblical verses and divine names

One of the most distinctive elements of Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed liturgy is the compilation of 112 biblical verses organized according to divine names. This specific number is not arbitrary but reflects deep kabbalistic significance tied to the very title of the work. The numerical value of the Hebrew letters in "Yabok" (יב״ק) equals 112, creating a direct correlation between the book's central metaphor and this collection of verses.

These 112 verses are further organized into three groups corresponding to three divine names: 21 verses for the divine name Ehyeh (אהי״ה), 26 verses for the Tetragrammaton (יקו״ק), and 65 verses for Adnut (אדנו״ת). Together, these three names total 112, matching the numerical value of YaBOK. The specificity of this arrangement reflects the text's meticulous attention to numeric symbolism as a vehicle for spiritual efficacy.

The divine name Ehyeh, meaning "I Will Be," appears in Exodus 3:14 when God identifies Himself to Moses at the burning bush as "Ehyeh asher Ehyeh" (I Am That I Am). In kabbalistic thought, this name represents God's self-sufficient existence beyond all limitation and corresponds to the highest divine attribute of Keter (Crown). The 21 verses associated with this name focus primarily on divine protection, mercy, and transcendence.

The Tetragrammaton (YHVH), Judaism's most sacred divine name, has the numerical value of 26 (10+5+6+5), explaining why exactly 26 verses are included in this section. In kabbalistic thought, this name represents God's eternal, unchanging essence and is associated with the divine attribute of Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony). The verses in this section emphasize divine compassion, covenant faithfulness, and redemption.

The divine name Adnut (often vocalized as Adonai, "my Lord") has a numerical value of 65 and represents God's sovereignty and immanence—the divine presence as experienced in the world. In the kabbalistic system, this name corresponds to the divine attribute of Malkhut (Kingdom). The 65 verses in this section focus on themes of divine judgment, governance, and manifestation in the physical world.

The arrangement of these verses is not merely symbolic but serves a practical spiritual purpose. According to Ma'avar Yabok, when recited at the deathbed, these verses create a protected spiritual pathway for the soul's ascent through various cosmic realms. Each verse is understood to generate a spiritual entity that accompanies and guides the soul, with the complete set of 112 verses creating a comprehensive protective framework.

The methodology for selecting these particular verses involved both thematic relevance and letter-counting techniques derived from kabbalistic practice. Many verses contain references to salvation, divine protection, or soul ascension. Others were chosen because they contain letter combinations that spell out divine names or because their first and last letters form meaningful acronyms when combined.

The verses are to be recited in sequence, beginning with those associated with Ehyeh, proceeding to those connected to the Tetragrammaton, and concluding with those linked to Adnut. This progression mirrors the soul's journey from the highest divine realms (represented by Ehyeh) through intermediate realms (Tetragrammaton) to the lower realms most connected to physical existence (Adnut). When recited in the proper order, these verses are believed to create a complete circuit of

divine energy that facilitates the soul's transition.

Ma'avar Yabok provides specific instructions regarding how these verses should be recited. They should be spoken clearly but not too loudly, with careful attention to pronunciation. Ideally, they should be recited by someone knowledgeable in Torah who understands their significance, though in the absence of such a person, any Jewish adult may recite them. If the dying person is conscious and able, they may participate in the recitation, but this is not required for the verses to benefit their soul.

The timing of this recitation is important. The verses should be begun when death appears imminent but not so early that they must be repeated multiple times. The text suggests that those experienced in attending the dying develop an intuition about the appropriate moment to begin this recitation. If death does not occur during the initial recitation, the verses may be repeated as necessary.

The compilation includes verses from all sections of the Hebrew Bible—Torah (Pentateuch), Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings)—creating a comprehensive representation of scripture. This inclusivity reflects the belief that the entire biblical canon contains divine power that can be activated through proper recitation. The selected verses range from well-known passages like the Priestly Blessing (Numbers 6:24–26) to more obscure texts that contain particular letter combinations with mystical significance.

Beyond their specific content, the rhythmic recitation of these 112 verses creates an atmosphere of sacred focus that benefits both the dying person and those in attendance. The structured liturgy provides a framework for channeling emotion and intention during what might otherwise be an overwhelming experience. For the companions of the dying, the recitation offers a way to be actively helpful rather than passively witnessing, while for the dying person, the familiar biblical language provides spiritual reassurance.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that these verses serve multiple functions simultaneously: they protect the departing soul from harmful spiritual forces, create a direct channel between the deathbed and divine realms, activate the supernal mercy of the three divine names they represent, and generate angelic escorts that accompany the soul on its journey. This multilayered effectiveness makes them a central component of the deathbed ritual system.

The practice illustrates the Jewish tradition's sophisticated integration of numerology, biblical exegesis, and mystical theology into practical ritual applications. Far from being arbitrary, the selection and arrangement of these 112 verses represents a carefully constructed spiritual technology designed to activate divine names and attributes at a crucial moment of transition.

Spiritual intentions (Kavvanot) and practicality

Ma'avar Yabok places great emphasis on proper intention (kavvanah) during deathbed rituals, teaching that the same actions performed with or without appropriate spiritual focus produce dramatically different results. For those attending the dying, the text provides detailed guidance on both the internal attitudes and external practices that facilitate a peaceful transition for the departing soul.

At the most basic level, those present should maintain an attitude of reverence and compassion. The deathbed is understood as a sacred space where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) dwells, demanding conduct similar to that observed in a synagogue. Frivolous conversation, laughter, or distraction is strictly prohibited. Instead, attendants should focus their thoughts on divine mercy and the soul's peaceful transition. The text recommends silent prayer when not actively engaged in prescribed rituals, maintaining an atmosphere of sacred attention.

For those with kabbalistic training, Ma'avar Yabok provides more elaborate instructions regarding specific divine names and configurations to visualize during different stages of the process. These include contemplating the unification of divine masculine and feminine attributes (represented by the divine names YHVH and ADNY), visualizing specific letter combinations that spell out divine names, and mentally connecting the dying person to various divine attributes associated with mercy rather than judgment.

The text emphasizes that proper intention during prayer and especially at the time of death involves precise visualization of divine names, their vowelization, and corresponding spiritual realms. It presents a sophisticated understanding of the four spiritual worlds (Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah) and how prayer and divine names function to elevate the soul through these worlds. Each soul component (Neshamah, Ruach, Nefesh) corresponds to different divine names and requires specific intentions for its elevation.

A central kavvanah practice described in Ma'avar Yabok involves the 42-letter Divine Name (Shem Mem-Bet), especially during the recitation of Isaiah's throne vision (Isaiah 6:1–3). The text provides detailed instructions for meditating on this name using specific visualizations that correspond to different spiritual worlds and divine configurations. These advanced practices are particularly recommended for those present at the death of a righteous person, creating unique opportunities for soul elevation and spiritual protection.

The text acknowledges that such complex kavvanot may be beyond the capability of many people, especially in the emotionally charged atmosphere of a deathbed. It therefore provides simpler alternatives that anyone can implement. These include focusing on divine mercy, visualizing light surrounding the dying person, and maintaining thoughts of divine unity expressed in the Shema prayer. The essential intention, accessible to all, involves recognizing death not as an ending but as a transition to another form of existence.

In addition to these internal intentions, Ma'avar Yabok provides extensive practical guidance for those attending the dying. When death appears imminent, attendants should ensure that the dying person is lying flat rather than in a seated position, which might impede the soul's departure. Pillows should be removed from beneath the head, symbolizing the return to earth and removing physical impediments to the soul's release.

The text includes specific instructions regarding the environment: windows should be opened (symbolizing an open path for the soul's ascent), mirrors should be covered (to prevent the soul from being confused by reflections), and any salt in the room should be removed (as it might attract harmful spiritual entities). Metal objects, particularly knives, should be removed from the vicinity of the dying person, as these too are believed to attract negative forces.

Practical guidance extends to the positioning of those attending the deathbed.

The text warns against standing at the foot of the bed, where the Angel of Death is believed to stand. Instead, attendants should position themselves at the head or sides of the bed. This arrangement creates a protected space for the dying person, surrounded by human presence that counterbalances the spiritual forces of judgment associated with death.

The practice of raising ten fingers toward heaven at the moment of death receives special attention. This gesture symbolizes acceptance of the Ten Commandments and submission to divine authority. It serves as a visual declaration of faith even when verbal declaration becomes impossible. The text explains that this practice creates a spiritual connection between the dying person and the divine realm, facilitating the soul's ascent.

Ma'avar Yabok also addresses post-mortem practices that should be prepared for in advance. These include closing the eyes and mouth immediately after death (preferably by the deceased's son if present), straightening the limbs while they are still flexible, and placing the body on the floor with feet pointing toward the door (symbolizing the soul's departure). These actions should be performed with reverence and gentleness, acknowledging that the recently departed soul remains aware of how its body is treated.

The text emphasizes the importance of continuous prayer and recitation of psalms from the moment of death until burial. Specific psalms are recommended, particularly Psalm 91 (known as "The Song of Afflictions"), which is believed to have special protective power against harmful spiritual forces. Those attending the body should not leave it alone, maintaining a continuous watch that serves both practical and spiritual purposes.

Throughout these instructions, Ma'avar Yabok balances technical ritual requirements with profound compassion. The kavvanot and practical guidelines serve not only the spiritual needs of the departing soul but also provide structure and meaning for those in attendance, transforming what could be a chaotic and frightening experience into a sacred ritual with deep significance. The text repeatedly emphasizes that proper intention transforms even simple actions into powerful spiritual tools that facilitate the soul's journey and bring comfort to both the dying and those who remain.

The enduring relevance of deathbed practices

The deathbed practices detailed in Ma'avar Yabok represent a sophisticated ritual system that addresses both practical and spiritual dimensions of the transition from life to death. While developed within a specific historical and cultural context, these practices contain wisdom that remains relevant even in our contemporary setting, offering potential resources for addressing the often-sanitized and medicalized approach to death in modern society.

At their core, these rituals acknowledge death as a significant spiritual transition rather than merely a medical event. By creating a sacred framework around the deathbed, they transform what might otherwise be experienced as chaotic and frightening into something meaningful and structured. The gathering of community, the recitation of ancient texts, and the performance of specific ritual actions all serve to place individual death within a larger cosmic and communal context.

The emphasis on conscious preparation for death presents a striking alternative to modern tendencies to avoid discussing death until it becomes imminent. Ma'avar Yabok's insistence on truthful communication with the dying, albeit with appropriate sensitivity, challenges contemporary practices that sometimes prioritize false hope over meaningful closure. The text suggests that acknowledging the reality of approaching death enables important spiritual work that might otherwise remain undone.

The confessional practices outlined in the text offer a model for life review and spiritual closure that has psychological as well as religious value. The process of acknowledging imperfection, seeking reconciliation, and ultimately accepting mortality represents a profound form of psychological integration that can benefit even those outside the specific religious tradition. Modern hospice and palliative care approaches increasingly recognize the importance of such life review processes in facilitating peaceful death.

The communal dimension of these deathbed practices—particularly the gathering of a minyan—stands in stark contrast to the isolation that often characterizes death in modern medical settings. By insisting that death should occur within community, the tradition acknowledges both the dying person's continued membership in the human collective and the community's responsibility toward its dying member. This mutual recognition of obligation and belonging can serve as a corrective to the sometimes atomized experience of modern death.

The structured liturgy of psalms, prayers, and biblical verses creates a shared language for approaching death that many find lacking in contemporary society. When words fail in the face of mortality, these ancient texts provide a vocabulary for expressing complex emotions and spiritual aspirations. Even for those who may not subscribe to their theological premises, these texts can offer poetic and symbolic resources for articulating the often inexpressible experience of confronting death.

Perhaps most significantly, Ma'avar Yabok's approach frames death not as a failure to be avoided at all costs but as a transition to be approached with appropriate preparation and spiritual intention. This perspective offers a meaningful alternative to both excessive medical intervention that may prolong suffering and nihilistic views that see in death only meaningless cessation. Instead, death becomes a sacred passage—a crossing of the Jabbok—that can be approached with dignity, meaning, and proper spiritual preparation.

The enduring relevance of these practices lies not necessarily in their literal application but in the wisdom they embody about how humans might approach mortality. They suggest that death is best faced consciously rather than denied, communally rather than in isolation, with structured ritual rather than improvisational confusion, and with attention to both practical and spiritual dimensions. These insights transcend their specific religious context and speak to universal human needs in confronting our mortality.

Ma'avar Yabok reminds us that how we die matters—not just medically but spiritually and communally. In an age that often struggles to find meaningful approaches to death, these ancient practices offer wisdom worthy of renewed consideration, even as they are adapted to contemporary circumstances and diverse religious perspectives. The crossing of the Jabbok remains a powerful metaphor for the journey we all must eventually undertake, and the rituals that facilitate this crossing continue to offer guidance for that universal human passage.

Appendix F

Jewish mourning customs

In Jewish tradition, death is not merely an ending but a transition—a crossing over from one state of existence to another. This concept is central to *Ma'avar Yabok*, whose very title evokes Jacob's biblical crossing of the Jabbok River, serving as a powerful metaphor for the soul's journey from this world to the next. The customs and rituals surrounding death and mourning in Judaism reflect this understanding of death as a passage rather than an annihilation, with each practice carrying both practical significance for the living and mystical implications for the deceased's soul.

The Jewish approach to death and mourning represents a carefully structured system that acknowledges the psychological needs of mourners while providing a framework for the soul's transition. Far from being merely consolatory measures, these practices are understood—particularly in mystical traditions—as active interventions that affect the deceased's spiritual journey. In the kabbalistic worldview presented in *Ma'avar Yabok*, physical actions performed by the living create corresponding spiritual effects in higher realms, directly influencing the soul's experience after death.

This appendix explores the multifaceted dimensions of Jewish mourning customs, examining both their practical implementation and their deeper mystical significance as elucidated in *Ma'avar Yabok* and related kabbalistic texts. While modern readers may approach these traditions from varying perspectives—historical, anthropological, psychological, or religious—understanding their mystical underpinnings provides crucial insight into how these practices were conceived and experienced by those who observed them with full conviction in their cosmic significance.

The soul's journey after death

Before examining specific mourning customs, we must first understand the Jewish mystical conception of what happens to the soul after death, as this provides the essential context for mourning practices. According to kabbalistic teachings presented in *Ma'avar Yabok*, the soul is not a simple, unitary entity but a complex, multi-layered construction with different components that experience different fates after death.

The soul is traditionally understood to have three primary components: *nefesh* (vital soul), *ruach* (spirit), and *neshamah* (higher soul), with some kabbalistic sys-

tems adding two additional, more transcendent levels—*chayah* and *yechidah*. Upon death, these different aspects of the soul separate and embark on distinct journeys:

The *nefesh*, which is most closely associated with the physical body, remains near the grave for a time. This explains the custom of visiting gravesites, as the *nefesh* is understood to be aware of those who come to pay respects. *Ma'avar Yabok* states explicitly that "the *nefesh* dwells near the grave" and maintains a connection to the physical remains, particularly through the indestructible *luz* bone (traditionally located at the base of the spine or under the skull), which serves as the physical nucleus for eventual resurrection.

The *ruach* ascends to the lower Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden Tachton*), a spiritual realm where it undergoes purification and spiritual development. This intermediate state allows the soul to process its earthly experiences and prepare for higher ascension.

The *neshamah*, the highest of the three primary soul components, ascends to the upper Garden of Eden (*Gan Eden Elyon*), where it experiences direct divine illumination and spiritual bliss. The *neshamah*'s experience depends on the spiritual merit accumulated during life, particularly through Torah study and mitzvot.

This tripartite division of the soul's afterlife journey creates a complex, multilayered understanding of what happens after death, with different aspects of the deceased's soul simultaneously experiencing different states in different realms. Rather than a simple ascension to heaven or descent to punishment, the Jewish mystical tradition presents a nuanced cosmology where parts of the soul may be experiencing purification in Gehinnom (a realm of spiritual cleansing often mistranslated as "hell") while other parts reside in various levels of Gan Eden.

Importantly, these different soul components do not remain permanently separated. During sacred times like Sabbath and festivals, they temporarily reunite, and they will ultimately be fully reunited during the resurrection of the dead. This understanding informs many mourning customs, particularly the structured timeframes that align with the soul's progressive journey through these spiritual realms.

Stages of mourning and their mystical significance

Jewish mourning is structured into distinct periods, each corresponding to different phases of the soul's journey and different psychological needs of the mourners. This temporal organization reflects both practical wisdom about the grieving process and mystical insights about the soul's transition through various spiritual realms. *Ma'avar Yabok* provides extensive commentary on these periods, revealing their deeper significance within the kabbalistic worldview.

Aninut: before burial

The period between death and burial is called *aninut* (acute grief), and the mourner during this time is called an *onen*. This phase is characterized by a focus on practical arrangements for burial rather than formal mourning observances. The *onen* is exempt from positive commandments like prayer and tefillin, reflecting both the prioritization of burial arrangements and a distinct spiritual state.

In *Ma'avar Yabok*, this exemption is explained through kabbalistic terminology: the *onen* exists temporarily outside both the "masculine realm" (*alma d'dechura*)

associated with expansion and mercy, and the "feminine realm" (*alma d'nukba*) associated with contraction and judgment. This liminal state reflects the cosmic disruption caused by death, where normal spiritual channels are temporarily suspended.

Mystically, *aninut* corresponds to the initial phase of the soul's journey, when it is in a state of shock and disorientation, having just separated from the body. The soul remains near the body during this time, which explains the tradition of not leaving the deceased alone before burial and the practice of maintaining a vigil (*shemirah*).

According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, during this period, the soul is particularly vulnerable to harmful spiritual forces and requires protection through proper rituals and the presence of the living. The exemption from mitzvot during *aninut* reflects not just the practical needs of the mourner but also this cosmic vulnerability, where the normal channels of divine influence are temporarily disrupted.

Shiva: seven days of mourning

Following burial, the formal mourning period of *shiva* (seven days) begins. This period corresponds to a significant transition in the soul's journey. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, during these seven days, the soul travels back and forth between the grave and its new spiritual dwelling, unable to fully depart from its physical location until this period is complete.

The number seven carries profound cosmic significance in kabbalistic thought. It corresponds to the seven lower *sefirot* (divine emanations) through which divine energy flows into the world: *Chesed* (Loving-kindness), *Gevurah* (Strength/Judgment), *Tiferet* (Beauty/Harmony), *Netzach* (Victory/Eternity), *Hod* (Splendor), *Yesod* (Foundation), and *Malkhut* (Kingdom). The seven days of *shiva* represent a process of cosmic reorganization where the soul, having been separated from its physical vessel, must reestablish its connection to these divine channels in a new, non-physical configuration.

Each day of *shiva* corresponds to one of these *sefirot*, creating a structured progression through which the soul ascends. This explains why the intensity of mourning gradually decreases over the seven days, mirroring the soul's progressive elevation and stabilization. The mourning practices observed during *shiva* are understood not merely as expressions of grief but as active interventions that assist the soul in this process of cosmic reorientation.

Ma'avar Yabok particularly emphasizes the first three days of *shiva* as a time of intense connection between the soul and the body. During this period, the soul "hovers over the body," experiencing the beginning stages of separation but not yet fully detached. This explains the tradition that the most intense expressions of grief are appropriate only during these first three days.

Sheloshim: thirty days

Following *shiva*, mourning continues in a less intense form for a total of thirty days (including the seven days of *shiva*). This thirty-day period, called *sheloshim*, corresponds to further stages in the soul's journey. According to kabbalistic teachings in *Ma'avar Yabok*, during these thirty days, the soul must ascend through thirty

spiritual levels—ten in each of the three lower worlds of *Asiyah* (Action), *Yetzirah* (Formation), and *Beriah* (Creation)—before it can reach the highest world of *Atzilut* (Emanation).

The number thirty also corresponds to the "thirty paths of wisdom" mentioned in *Sefer Yetzirah*, representing complete spiritual understanding. As the soul traverses these paths, it gains increased comprehension of its life experiences and their spiritual significance.

During *sheloshim*, mourning practices become less restrictive, reflecting the soul's increased stability and decreased vulnerability. Mourners gradually return to normal life activities while still observing certain restrictions, mirroring the soul's gradual adaptation to its new state of existence.

Twelve months for parents

For parents only, mourning continues in its most minimal form for twelve months (traditionally reduced in practice to eleven months due to theological considerations about the status of the deceased). This extended period reflects the special relationship between parent and child, which in kabbalistic thought extends beyond physical existence into the spiritual realms.

According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, during this period, the soul undergoes its final purification before reaching its ultimate place in the afterlife. The text emphasizes that a child's actions during this period directly affect the parent's spiritual status. This creates a reciprocal relationship where the deceased parent may intercede for the living child in heavenly realms, while the child's righteous actions elevate the parent's soul.

The twelve-month period corresponds to the twelve months of the year and the twelve tribes of Israel, representing a complete cosmic cycle during which the soul experiences all facets of divine influence before achieving its final rest. It also parallels the maximum duration of punishment in Gehinnom, suggesting that mourning practices during this time may help mitigate or eliminate such purificatory suffering for the deceased.

Key mourning practices

Beyond the temporal structure of mourning, specific ritual practices carry profound mystical significance. These practices are not merely symbolic but are understood in the kabbalistic worldview as direct interventions that affect the soul's journey through spiritual realms.

Keriah: tearing of garments

One of the most visually striking mourning rituals is *keriah*, the tearing of garments. Traditionally, upon receiving news of the death of a close relative, one tears their clothing—on the right side for parents (over the heart) and on the left side for other relatives. This practice has complex mystical dimensions explored in *Ma'avar Yabok*.

According to kabbalistic teachings, *keriah* represents the cosmic tear that occurs at death, when the soul is forcibly separated from the body. The physical action

of tearing garments mirrors and in some sense repairs this metaphysical rupture. The text explains that *keriah* helps the soul transition from the "feminine realm" (*alma d'nukba*, associated with physical existence) to the "masculine realm" (*alma d'dechura*, associated with spiritual existence).

The distinction between tearing on the right for parents versus the left for other relatives reflects the kabbalistic association of the right side with *Chesed* (Loving-kindness) and the left with *Gevurah* (Judgment). Parents, having provided unconditional love and nurture, are mourned through the side of mercy, while other relationships, being more conditional, are mourned through the side of judgment.

Furthermore, *keriah* is understood to have protective spiritual power, deterring harmful spiritual forces that might impede the soul's journey. By publicly acknowledging death through this dramatic action, mourners create a spiritual shield around both themselves and the deceased, preventing negative energies from exploiting the vulnerability created by death.

Sitting low and covering mirrors

During *shiva*, mourners traditionally sit on low stools or cushions and cover mirrors in the house of mourning. These practices, beyond their psychological significance, carry mystical implications detailed in *Ma'avar Yabok*.

Sitting low symbolizes the mourner's spiritual descent, paralleling the soul's journey downward before it can ascend to higher realms. In kabbalistic terms, this practice aligns the mourner with the divine attribute of *Malkhut* (Kingdom), the lowest *sefirah*, which is associated with physical existence and often described as "dust." By literally lowering themselves, mourners create a mystical connection with the deceased, who has descended to the most physical level (the grave) before beginning spiritual ascent.

Covering mirrors reflects the kabbalistic concept of *tzelem* (divine image) in which humans are created. Mirrors show the physical *tzelem*, but death focuses attention on the spiritual *tzelem* that has now departed. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, covering mirrors also prevents harmful spiritual forces from using reflective surfaces as gateways between worlds, protecting both the deceased's soul and the vulnerable mourners from negative influences.

Restrictions on activities and physical comfort

During mourning periods, particularly *shiva*, numerous restrictions apply: mourners do not wear leather shoes, engage in marital relations, study Torah (except topics related to mourning), bathe for pleasure, use perfumes or lotions, engage in business, or attend celebrations. These restrictions serve both psychological and mystical purposes.

From the mystical perspective articulated in *Ma'avar Yabok*, these practices align the mourner's physical experience with the soul's journey through judgment. The soul, undergoing evaluation and purification in spiritual realms, experiences a form of discomfort as it adjusts to its new existence. By voluntarily accepting physical restrictions, mourners create a corresponding reality that assists the soul's transition.

The restriction against leather shoes specifically relates to the kabbalistic concept of separating from the physical world. Leather, derived from animals, represents attachment to physical existence. Walking without leather creates greater awareness of the earth, symbolizing the soul's new awareness of its spiritual foundations after being separated from physical embodiment.

The prohibition against Torah study (except topics related to mourning) reflects the soul's initial inability to fully engage with divine wisdom in its disoriented post-death state. As *Ma'avar Yabok* explains, the soul must first undergo purification before it can access the higher pleasures of Torah study in the afterlife. The mourner's temporary abstention from Torah mirrors and supports this process.

Washing hands after the cemetery

The custom of washing hands after visiting a cemetery has practical hygiene considerations but also profound mystical significance elaborated in *Ma'avar Yabok*. This ritual washing involves pouring water over each hand three times, alternating between right and left, without blessing or drying the hands before leaving the cemetery grounds.

Kabbalistically, this practice serves multiple purposes: it removes the "spirit of impurity" (*ruach hatumah*) that clings to visitors from the realm of death; it creates a definitive boundary between the world of the living and the dead; and it symbolizes the soul's eventual purification through the "rivers of balsam" mentioned in rabbinic literature.

The threefold washing corresponds to the three levels of the soul (*nefesh*, *ruach*, and *neshamah*), creating a mystical cleansing that affects all dimensions of the mourner's spiritual being. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, when performed with proper intention, this washing also benefits the deceased by symbolically cleansing their soul as it moves between spiritual realms.

The practice of not passing the water vessel directly between people (instead placing it on the ground) prevents the direct transmission of death-related spiritual forces between individuals. This reflects the kabbalistic understanding that spiritual influences can be conducted through objects, particularly water, which serves as a medium for transferring or dispersing spiritual forces.

Recitation of Kaddish

Perhaps the most well-known mourning practice is the recitation of Kaddish, a prayer in Aramaic that, surprisingly, makes no mention of death but instead sanctifies God's name. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, Kaddish serves as a powerful mystical tool for elevating the deceased's soul through multiple spiritual realms.

When mourners recite Kaddish and the congregation responds "Amen, may His great name be blessed forever and ever," they create what kabbalists call a "crown" for the divine presence. This mystical crown facilitates the soul's ascent through various heavenly palaces. The public sanctification of God's name generates spiritual merit that directly benefits the deceased, potentially releasing them from judgment in Gehinnom and elevating them to higher levels in Gan Eden.

The Kaddish's Aramaic language is significant in kabbalistic thought. Aramaic is considered an "intermediate" language between Hebrew (the holy tongue) and

other languages. This intermediacy makes it particularly suitable for a prayer that seeks to bridge worlds—connecting the realm of the living with the realm of the dead, and lower spiritual worlds with higher ones.

Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that when children recite Kaddish for parents, they create a unique spiritual channel that directly influences the parent's posthumous experience. This reflects the kabbalistic principle that children are mystically connected to their parents through the "root of their soul," allowing their actions to affect their parents' spiritual status even after death.

Mourning foods and their mystical significance

The food customs associated with Jewish mourning are rich with kabbalistic symbolism explained in detail in *Ma'avar Yabok*. These customs are not merely comforting traditions but mystical practices with specific spiritual effects.

The meal of consolation

The first meal after a funeral, called *seudat havra'ah* (meal of consolation), is traditionally provided by neighbors rather than prepared by the mourners themselves. This meal typically includes round foods like eggs and lentils, bread, and wine. Each element carries mystical significance in the kabbalistic worldview.

According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, eggs symbolize the cyclical nature of life and death, their rounded shape representing the "wheel of existence" that continues turning despite individual mortality. More profoundly, eggs represent "reflected light" (*or chozer*) in kabbalistic thought, corresponding to the divine attribute of *Malkhut* (Kingdom) and the feminine aspect of divinity. This reflected light symbolizes how the soul, after death, receives divine illumination indirectly, as it gradually adjusts to spiritual existence.

Lentils, also round, carry additional symbolism through their association with Jacob's lentil stew, which he prepared when Abraham died (according to midrashic interpretation). Kabbalistically, lentils correspond to the divine attribute of *Din* (Judgment), which predominates during mourning. Their red color connects them to the sefirotic quality of *Gevurah* (Strength/Judgment), while their circular shape suggests the continuous cycle of divine judgment and mercy.

Bread represents the divine attribute of *Tiferet* (Beauty/Harmony), the central balance point of the sefirotic system. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, bread at the meal of consolation creates a mystical connection to this harmonizing force, helping to reestablish cosmic balance disrupted by death.

Wine corresponds to the kabbalistic concept of the "Tree of Life" when used properly in ritual contexts. The blessing over wine during the mourner's meal creates a channel of divine life-force that benefits both the living and the deceased. The red color of wine also represents the transformation of judgment (*Din*) into mercy (*Rachamim*), a central goal of mourning rituals in kabbalistic thought.

Hard-boiled eggs and the Ninth of Av

Hard-boiled eggs are also traditionally eaten at the meal before the fast of the Ninth of Av, the day commemorating the destruction of both Temples in Jerusalem. This

parallel between personal and national mourning is not coincidental in kabbalistic thought. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, individual death and national destruction reflect the same cosmic principle of divine judgment manifesting in different scales.

The egg's smooth surface without mouth or opening symbolizes mourners who often find themselves speechless in their grief. Just as the egg contains life potential within a seemingly lifeless shell, death contains the potential for resurrection and renewal. The hard-boiling of eggs for mourning meals represents the "hardening" of normal life during mourning periods, a temporary state that will eventually give way to renewed vitality.

Comforting mourners and its mystical dimensions

The mitzvah of *nichum avelim* (comforting mourners) extends beyond its obvious psychological benefits into mystical realms. *Ma'avar Yabok* provides extensive guidance on both the practical and spiritual dimensions of this important practice.

According to kabbalistic teachings in the text, comforting mourners should ideally take place in the location where the person died, as the soul continues to "mourn" in this place for seven days after death. The presence of ten worthy people (a minyan) in this location brings the Divine Presence (*Shekhinah*), providing comfort to both the mourners and the deceased's soul.

The traditional formula for comforting mourners—"May the Omnipresent comfort you among the other mourners of Zion and Jerusalem"—creates a mystical connection between individual loss and national mourning. This formula, according to *Ma'avar Yabok*, activates cosmic channels that bring divine consolation not just to the individual mourners but to the entire community of Israel and ultimately to the Divine Presence itself, which "mourns" the destruction of the Temple and the dispersion of Israel.

When entering a house of mourning, visitors traditionally remain silent until the mourner speaks first. This practice reflects the kabbalistic understanding that death creates a spiritual rupture that affects the normal flow of divine energy. By allowing mourners to initiate conversation, visitors acknowledge this disrupted state and avoid imposing external speech patterns that might interfere with the mourner's spiritual process.

The mitzvah of comforting mourners is considered one of the acts of kindness (*gemilut chasadim*) that affects cosmic realms. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, such acts transform harsh judgment (*din*) into mercy (*rachamim*), creating effects that ripple through multiple spiritual worlds. When performed with proper intention, comforting mourners not only aids the bereaved psychologically but also assists the deceased's soul in navigating post-mortem spiritual realms.

Yahrzeit observance and ongoing connections

The annual commemoration of a death date, called *yahrzeit* (Yiddish for "year time"), carries significant mystical importance in *Ma'avar Yabok*. This observance, marked by lighting a 24-hour memorial candle and reciting Kaddish, creates a spiritual connection between worlds that benefits both the living and the dead.

According to kabbalistic teachings, on the anniversary of death, the soul experiences a type of "spiritual elevation" as it ascends to higher levels in the afterlife. The yahrzeit candle provides what mystics call a "garment of light" that assists the soul in this elevation. The flame's upward motion symbolizes the soul's ascent, while its physical presence in the world of the living creates a tangible connection to the world of souls.

The text emphasizes that when children observe yahrzeit for parents, they activate the mystical principle that "a son brings merit to his father" (*bara mezakeh abba*). This creates a reciprocal spiritual relationship where the deceased parent may intercede for the child in heavenly realms, while the child's actions continue to elevate the parent's soul.

Beyond individual yahrzeit observances, community memorial services (*Yizkor*) held four times annually (on Yom Kippur, Shemini Atzeret, the last day of Passover, and Shavuot) create collective channels for soul elevation. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, these communal remembrances are particularly powerful because they combine the merit of the entire congregation, creating a stronger spiritual effect than individual memorials alone.

Cemetery visits and prayers at graves

Visiting graves and praying at burial sites represents another important dimension of Jewish mourning practices with profound mystical significance elaborated in *Ma'avar Yabok*. These visits are not merely symbolic but create actual spiritual effects according to kabbalistic understanding.

The text explains that when visiting a grave, one should place their left hand on the tombstone while praying, creating a physical connection to the deceased that facilitates spiritual communication. Specific prayers recited at gravesites are understood to directly benefit the soul, particularly when they include charitable pledges made in the deceased's memory.

According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, visiting graves initiates a mystical chain reaction: the living person's presence activates the *nefesh* that remains near the grave, which in turn communicates with the *ruach* in the lower Garden of Eden, which then connects to the *neshamah* in the upper Garden of Eden. This creates a complete channel through which prayers and good deeds can elevate the soul to higher spiritual levels.

The custom of placing small stones on graves after a visit carries kabbalistic significance beyond its practical function of marking that someone has visited. These stones, according to mystical interpretation, create a spiritual "barrier" that protects the deceased from negative forces and symbolizes the permanence of memory against the erosion of time.

Graves of righteous individuals (*tzaddikim*) are considered particularly powerful spiritual locations. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that the souls of the righteous can serve as intermediaries, elevating prayers offered near their burial places. When one invokes the merit of the righteous deceased through the formula "by the merit of [name]," they activate a mystical channel through which divine blessing can flow more readily to address their needs.

Gender in traditional mourning practices

While *Ma'avar Yabok* was written in a historical context where gender roles were strictly defined, it does address both men's and women's mourning obligations, revealing interesting mystical dimensions to gender differences in mourning practices.

In traditional Jewish practice, certain mourning obligations fell primarily to men, particularly public rituals like Kaddish recitation. However, *Ma'avar Yabok* emphasizes that women's spiritual practices—particularly their three special mitzvot of *niddah* (family purity), *challah* (separating dough), and *hadlakat nerot* (lighting candles)—carry tremendous mystical power that can benefit deceased souls.

The text explains that women's candle-lighting creates spiritual illumination that guides souls through the darkness between worlds. It describes a kabbalistic correspondence between the components of a lamp and the letters of the divine name (YHVH): the vessel corresponds to the lower *hei*, the wick to *vav*, the oil to *yod*, and the flame to the upper *hei*. Through this practice, women directly affect divine unification in higher realms.

Similarly, women's observance of family purity laws creates cosmic purification that extends beyond the physical realm. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, these practices repair the damage from primordial sin and protect women from negative spiritual forces while creating channels for divine blessing that benefit both the living and the dead.

The text acknowledges women's traditional role in preparing the deceased for burial, particularly washing and dressing female bodies. This sacred task of *tahara* (purification) carries profound mystical significance, as women engaging in this mitzvah create corresponding purification for the soul in spiritual realms.

The living and the dead in cosmic harmony

Jewish mourning practices, as elucidated in *Ma'avar Yabok*, reveal a worldview where the boundaries between life and death, physical and spiritual realms, are permeable rather than absolute. The intricate system of mourning customs reflects a sophisticated understanding of how actions in this world create corresponding effects in higher realms, directly influencing the soul's posthumous journey.

These practices serve multiple functions simultaneously: they provide psychological support for mourners; they create communal solidarity in the face of loss; they preserve cultural memory and identity; and, according to mystical understanding, they actively assist the deceased's soul in navigating the complex transition between worlds. The temporal structure of mourning periods mirrors the soul's gradual adaptation to spiritual existence, while specific rituals create channels through which divine energy flows to both comfort the living and elevate the dead.

Perhaps most profoundly, the Jewish approach to mourning articulated in *Ma'avar Yabok* reveals a vision of ongoing relationship between the living and the dead. Rather than a complete separation, death initiates a transformation in how souls relate to one another. The mystical framework provides comfort by affirming that those who have died continue to exist, albeit in different form, and remain connected to the living through prayers, rituals, and shared spiritual destiny.

For the modern reader, regardless of personal belief in the mystical dimensions described in *Ma'avar Yabok*, understanding these teachings provides valuable insight into how traditional Jewish communities conceptualized death and mourning. It reveals that behind seemingly simple customs lie complex theological and cosmological systems that frame human mortality within a larger narrative of spiritual purpose and ultimate redemption.

The Jewish mourning practices outlined here continue to evolve in contemporary Jewish communities, with varying levels of adherence to traditional forms. Yet the underlying principles—structured time for grief, communal support, meaningful ritual action, and affirmation of ongoing spiritual connection—remain powerful resources for confronting the universal human experience of loss and bereavement. In this way, the wisdom of *Ma'avar Yabok* continues to offer guidance for crossing the metaphorical Jabbok River that separates life from death, accompanying souls on both sides of this profound transition.

Appendix G

Tahara (ritual washing) and burial preparations

The care of the dead in Jewish tradition represents a distinctive nexus where practical necessity meets profound spiritual significance. Within the pages of Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena presents a comprehensive framework for these practices, consistently emphasizing their dual nature as both physical actions and cosmic interventions. Central to this framework is the Chevra Kadisha, the burial society whose members perform what Jewish tradition considers the ultimate act of kindness—preparing the deceased for burial.

The Chevra Kadisha (literally "Holy Society") occupies a position of particular reverence within Jewish communal structures. Unlike many other religious functionaries, these individuals perform their sacred duties largely unseen, caring for those who can never acknowledge or reciprocate their efforts. Ma'avar Yabok elevates these societies beyond mere functional necessity, portraying them as agents of divine service whose actions create profound spiritual effects. The author refers to them with exalted language as "priests" and "emissaries of the Merciful One," terminology that connects their work to the ancient Temple service and emphasizes the sacred nature of their undertaking.

The text reveals that Aaron Berechia's visit to Mantua significantly influenced his understanding of proper burial practices. He describes being deeply impressed by the piety and customs of Mantua's burial societies, particularly regarding death rituals and charitable activities. This experience appears to have provided practical models that he then integrated with his extensive kabbalistic knowledge to create Ma'avar Yabok's comprehensive approach to burial preparations. He notes that despite feeling unworthy, he was chosen to arrange prayer services in Mantua, suggesting direct experience with their funeral customs.

Members of the Chevra Kadisha traditionally prepare themselves spiritually before engaging in their sacred work. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes the importance of pure intentions (kavvanah) during all aspects of tahara, suggesting that those performing these rituals should understand their cosmic significance. The text implies that proper preparation involves not only practical knowledge but spiritual readiness—an awareness that one stands at the intersection between worlds, facilitating the soul's transition. This preparation might include prayer, contemplation of

one's own mortality, and specific ritual practices like hand washing before beginning the tahara process.

Ma'avar Yabok describes the work of the Chevra Kadisha as constituting chesed shel emet—"true kindness" or "kindness of truth." This phrase carries particular significance in Jewish thought, as it refers specifically to kindness shown to the dead, who cannot reciprocate or even acknowledge the kindness shown to them. The term appears in Genesis 47:29 when Jacob asks Joseph to show him "kindness and truth" (chesed ve'emet) by not burying him in Egypt, and has been understood in rabbinic tradition as referring specifically to burial and care for the dead. Aaron Berechia elevates this concept further by explaining that such kindness creates cosmic effects, establishing channels for divine mercy to flow into the world and aiding the soul's journey through various spiritual realms.

The ethical foundation for the Chevra Kadisha's work extends beyond mere respect for the deceased. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that proper treatment of the body affects the soul's experience after death. The text suggests that the soul remains aware of what happens to its physical vessel even after death, creating a profound ethical imperative for those handling the deceased. This awareness continues until the grave is sealed, underscoring the importance of treating the body with utmost dignity throughout the entire process from death to burial. This conception adds a dimension of urgency and sanctity to burial preparations that transcends mere cultural practice, establishing them as critical spiritual interventions during a vulnerable transitional period for the soul.

The text consistently emphasizes that members of the Chevra Kadisha should maintain silence during their work except when reciting prescribed prayers and verses. This silence serves both practical and mystical purposes—practically ensuring reverence and concentration, while mystically aligning with the rabbinic maxim that "the reward of the house of mourning is silence." Such silence creates a sacred atmosphere during tahara that honors the gravity of death while providing spiritual protection for both the deceased and those performing the rituals.

Initial procedures following death

Ma'avar Yabok provides detailed guidance for the immediate actions to be taken following death, each carrying both practical importance and spiritual significance. These initial procedures establish a foundation of respect and dignity that characterizes the entire process of burial preparation.

The moment of death initiates a series of carefully prescribed actions. The text instructs that ideally, the deceased's son should close the eyes, though any person present may perform this action if necessary. This practice reflects both practical dignity (as open eyes can create a disturbing appearance) and symbolic meaning, suggesting a peaceful transition into eternal sleep. The closing of the eyes also metaphorically represents the soul's shift from physical to spiritual perception, as Ma'avar Yabok explains that at death, perception transitions to allow the deceased to see departed souls and potentially the Divine Presence itself.

Following the closing of the eyes, the text prescribes straightening the limbs and positioning the body properly, with arms alongside the body rather than crossed on the chest (which would reflect non-Jewish burial customs). The body should be

placed on the ground, symbolizing the biblical statement that "from dust you came, and to dust you shall return" (Genesis 3:19). The text emphasizes that the body should not be left unattended from the moment of death until burial—a practice known as shemira (guarding). This continuous watching serves multiple purposes: it shows respect for the deceased, prevents rodents or other animals from disturbing the body, and provides spiritual protection against negative forces that Ma'avar Yabok suggests might otherwise harm the soul during this vulnerable transitional period.

The face of the deceased should be covered immediately after death, though the text specifies that those present should avoid gazing upon the face even before covering it. This practice reflects the Jewish principle of maintaining the dignity of the deceased by not subjecting them to unnecessary observation. Ma'avar Yabok connects this practice to deeper spiritual concepts, suggesting that the soul's departure alters the countenance in ways that should be respected through covering.

Another significant initial action is the ritual tearing of garments (keriah) by those witnessing the death. Ma'avar Yabok compares this practice to the response when witnessing a Torah scroll burn, establishing a profound connection between the human body and sacred texts. This comparison elevates the deceased human being to the level of sacred object, reinforcing the reverence with which the body should be treated. The text provides a kabbalistic interpretation of keriah as having cosmic significance, suggesting that it helps the soul transition from the "feminine realm" (alma d'nukva, associated with physical existence) to the "masculine realm" (alma d'dechura, associated with spiritual ascent).

Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that all jewelry and other objects should be removed from the body, reflecting the principle that all are equal in death regardless of wealth or status. The text explains that such adornments represent material attachments that could impede the soul's spiritual journey. Additionally, the book specifies that any blood-soaked clothing should be buried with the deceased, reflecting the mystical understanding that the soul is connected to the blood, and proper treatment of blood-soaked items affects the soul's transition.

Of particular importance is the instruction that the deceased should not be left alone until burial. Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes having ten Jews (a minyan) present at death as this creates a sacred space where the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) dwells, facilitating the soul's transition. The text explains that this requirement creates a spiritual environment described as "Mahanaim" (two camps)—where the human realm meets the angelic realm, creating a protected pathway for the soul's ascent. This principle continues through the requirement for shemira until burial.

All of these initial procedures are understood to have direct effects on the soul's experience after death. Ma'avar Yabok explains that until burial, the soul hovers near the body and remains aware of everything happening to it. This understanding creates a profound ethical imperative for those handling the deceased, as their actions directly impact the soul's experience during this transitional period. The text suggests that respectful, dignified treatment brings comfort to the soul, while neglect or improper handling causes it distress.

The Tahara process: ritual purification

The central element of burial preparation in Jewish tradition is tahara, the ritual purification of the body. Ma'avar Yabok presents this process not merely as physical cleansing but as a profound spiritual transition affecting multiple cosmic realms. The tahara ritual combines meticulous practical procedures with sophisticated kabbalistic interpretations that transform what might otherwise be seen as simple washing into a cosmic intervention facilitating the soul's journey.

The tahara process begins with practical preparations. The body is placed on a special board (the tahara board) designed specifically for this purpose, which is slightly inclined to allow water to flow down and away. The text emphasizes that all preparations should be made before bringing the body to the tahara room, ensuring that the deceased is not subjected to unnecessary delays or disturbances once the ritual begins. The room itself should be clean and prepared with all necessary items: containers of water, towels, combs, sheets for covering the body during various stages of the process, and the shrouds (tachrichim) that will eventually clothe the deceased.

Ma'avar Yabok prescribes that those performing tahara should wash their hands before beginning, symbolizing both physical cleanliness and spiritual purification. The text explicitly connects this practice to the kabbalistic concept of the ten fingers corresponding to the ten divine emanations (sefirot), suggesting that the washing of hands creates channels for divine influence to flow through the ritual actions that follow. This hand-washing represents the first of many actions during tahara that simultaneously serve practical and mystical purposes.

The actual washing process consists of two distinct phases. The first phase involves the cleaning of the body, removing any physical impurities. The text instructs that warm water should be used, and that the body should be treated with utmost respect and gentleness throughout. Those performing tahara are instructed to keep the body covered with a sheet as much as possible during this process, exposing only the portion being washed at any given time. This maintains the dignity of the deceased while also reflecting spiritual modesty. The text emphasizes that the body should never be turned face down, as this would be considered disrespectful.

During this initial cleaning, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes that specific verses from Song of Songs should be recited for different parts of the body, following a top-down order from head to feet. This practice reflects the kabbalistic understanding that the human form mirrors divine structures, with each body part corresponding to different aspects of the cosmic divine body. The text specifically recommends verses from Song of Songs 5:11-16, which poetically describe the beloved's body from head to feet:

- "His head is finest gold, his locks are wavy, black as a raven" for washing the head.
- "His eyes are like doves beside springs of water" for the eyes.
- "His cheeks are like beds of spices" for the face.
- "His lips are lilies, distilling liquid myrrh" for the mouth.
- "His hands are rods of gold, set with beryl" for the hands.

- "His legs are alabaster columns, set upon bases of gold" for the legs.

The use of these verses transforms physical washing into a spiritual reconsecration of the body, connecting each part to its divine counterpart and preparing it for its return to its source. This practice also reflects the Jewish understanding of Song of Songs as an allegory for the relationship between God and Israel, suggesting that tahara prepares the body for a spiritual reunion with the divine beloved.

Following the initial cleaning, the second phase of tahara involves pouring nine measures (kavin) of water over the entire body in a continuous flow. Ma'avar Yabok explains this practice in both practical and mystical terms. Practically, it ensures complete purification; mystically, it carries profound kabbalistic significance related to divine names and attributes. The text provides gematria (numerical) interpretations connecting the nine measures to various divine names and configurations, suggesting that this pouring creates spiritual channels through which the soul can ascend. The number nine itself is significant in kabbalistic thought, often associated with the sefirah of Yesod (Foundation), which serves as a channel between higher spiritual realms and the physical world.

During this pouring of water, specific biblical verses emphasizing purification are recited, including "I will sprinkle clean water upon you, and you shall be clean; from all your uncleannesses and from all your idols I will cleanse you" (Ezekiel 36:25). These verses explicitly connect physical washing with spiritual purification, reinforcing the dual nature of tahara as both bodily cleansing and soul preparation. The text emphasizes that the water should flow over the entire body without interruption, symbolizing complete purification.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that the tahara process operates simultaneously on physical and metaphysical levels. Physically, it cleanses the body, showing respect for the vessel that housed a divine soul; spiritually, it purifies the nefesh (lower soul component) that remains connected to the body even after death. The text suggests that proper tahara facilitates the soul's separation from physical attachments while providing spiritual protection during its journey through various realms. In kabbalistic terms, the washing ritual is understood to remove negative spiritual forces (kelipot) that might otherwise cling to the soul, allowing it to ascend more freely.

Of particular importance is the instruction that those performing tahara should maintain specific intentions (kavvanot) throughout the process. Ma'avar Yabok explains that proper intention transforms simple physical actions into cosmic interventions affecting multiple spiritual worlds. The text describes how each aspect of tahara—from hand washing to verse recitation to water pouring—creates effects in corresponding divine realms, particularly influencing the sefirot of Chesed (Loving-kindness) and Din (Judgment). These kavvanot ensure that tahara serves not merely as physical cleaning but as a comprehensive spiritual preparation facilitating the soul's transition.

After the washing and pouring of water is complete, the body is carefully dried. The text emphasizes that this should be done gently and respectfully, maintaining the deceased's dignity throughout. Once dried, the body is ready for dressing in burial shrouds, the next stage in the preparation process.

Tachrichim: The symbolic garments of eternity

Following the tahara process, the deceased is dressed in special burial garments known as tachrichim. Ma'avar Yabok presents these simple white shrouds not merely as practical coverings but as spiritually significant garments that prepare the soul for its journey and eventual resurrection. The simplicity and uniformity of tachrichim reflect the fundamental Jewish principle that all are equal in death, regardless of social status or wealth in life.

The text describes tachrichim as typically consisting of several separate white garments: an undergarment or pants (michnasayim), a shirt (kutonet), a head covering (mitznefet), and a face covering (sovev). These garments are traditionally made of simple white linen or cotton, without pockets, knots, or embellishments. Ma'avar Yabok explains that this simplicity serves multiple purposes: it honors the deceased by preventing embarrassment for those who cannot afford elaborate burial clothes, it symbolizes purity and the removal of worldly concerns, and it mystically prepares the body for resurrection.

The white color of tachrichim carries profound symbolic significance that Ma'avar Yabok explores in detail. White represents purity, drawing on the biblical verse, "Though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow" (Isaiah 1:18). It also symbolizes forgiveness, suggesting that the deceased has been purified of sins. The text connects this symbolism to the High Priest's white garments worn on Yom Kippur, implying that death itself serves as a form of atonement. This connection establishes an important theological framework where proper burial preparations participate in the deceased's spiritual purification.

Ma'avar Yabok presents a sophisticated kabbalistic interpretation of tachrichim, explaining that the different garments correspond to different components of the soul: the undergarments and leggings relate to the nefesh (vital soul), the shroud to the ruach (spirit), and the tallit to the neshamah (higher soul). This correspondence suggests that the dressing ritual addresses each aspect of the soul's complex structure, preparing all components for their respective journeys. The text further explains that these garments serve as spiritual vessels that continue to clothe the soul even after the physical garments decay, creating enduring spiritual protection during the soul's post-mortem journey.

The text prescribes specific verses to be recited during the dressing process, particularly from Song of Songs 4:14: "Nard and saffron, calamus and cinnamon, with all trees of frankincense, myrrh and aloes, with all chief spices." This verse metaphorically describes the deceased as being prepared with spiritual fragrances for their final journey. After completing the dressing, additional verses from Isaiah 61:10 are recited: "I will greatly rejoice in the LORD, my soul shall be joyful in my God; for He has clothed me with the garments of salvation, He has covered me with the robe of righteousness." These verses create a parallel between the physical dressing of the body and the spiritual garments of salvation that await the soul, transforming the practical act of clothing the deceased into a cosmic preparation for eternity.

For men who were married during their lifetime, the tallit (prayer shawl) holds special significance in burial preparations. Ma'avar Yabok provides detailed instructions for how the tallit should be treated: one of its ritual fringes (tzitzit) should be cut to render it ritually invalid, symbolizing that the deceased is no longer obligated

to perform commandments. However, the text emphasizes that the tallit should be positioned according to how the person wore it during life, honoring their personal religious customs even in death. According to the text, the tallit serves to protect the deceased from "forces of judgment" and brings the soul under divine protection, described metaphorically as "the wings of the Divine Presence."

Of particular interest is Ma'avar Yabok's explanation of the practice of including earth from the Land of Israel in burial preparations. The text describes a custom of placing a small amount of soil from the Holy Land under the deceased's head or sprinkling it over the body before burial. This practice carries multiple layers of significance: it connects the deceased to the sacred land even if they could not be buried there, it symbolically fulfills the wish of many diaspora Jews to be connected with Israel in death, and it mystically facilitates the soul's journey during resurrection. The text explains that bodies buried in the diaspora will need to "roll through underground passages" to reach the Land of Israel for resurrection, and including holy soil eases this process.

Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that throughout the dressing process, those preparing the body should maintain an awareness of the kabbalistic correspondences between physical actions and spiritual effects. The text suggests that proper intention during this process creates channels through which divine mercy can flow, aiding the soul's journey while establishing cosmic repairs (tikkunim) in higher realms. This dual awareness—attending simultaneously to practical details and spiritual significance—characterizes the book's entire approach to burial preparations.

Special cases and gender considerations

Ma'avar Yabok recognizes that while general principles apply to all burial preparations, certain circumstances require modified approaches. The text provides detailed guidance for various special cases, ensuring that even unusual situations can be handled with proper respect and appropriate ritual adaptation. Similarly, it acknowledges gender-specific considerations in tahara practices, reflecting both practical modesty concerns and deeper mystical understandings of masculine and feminine spiritual energies.

Regarding gender, the text establishes the fundamental principle that tahara should be performed by members of the same sex as the deceased. Men prepare male bodies, women prepare female bodies. This rule serves practical modesty concerns while also reflecting kabbalistic understandings of gender complementarity in spiritual realms. The separation extends beyond the tahara itself to funeral processions, where Ma'avar Yabok warns about strict gender separation, with men and women not only walking separately but at different times. The text explains this requirement through the belief that the Angel of Death is especially powerful when men and women are mixed during funeral proceedings, suggesting that proper separation provides spiritual protection during this vulnerable time.

For women, Ma'avar Yabok includes special considerations related to their distinctive religious obligations. The text specifically emphasizes the importance of tahara for women who may have died while in a state of niddah (ritual impurity related to menstruation), suggesting that proper purification affects their soul's journey. Additionally, the book connects women's burial preparations to the three

essential mitzvot particularly incumbent upon women: niddah (family purity), challah (separating dough), and hadlakat ha-ner (candle lighting). The text explains how proper burial rituals help rectify any shortcomings in these areas during life.

For those who died violently, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes specific modified practices. The text instructs that murder victims should be buried separately from other deceased, left in their clothes rather than dressed in shrouds, and wrapped with a sheet over these clothes. These modifications stem from the mystical understanding that the souls of murder victims actively seek justice against their killers and remain in a distinct spiritual state until vengeance is achieved. The text explains that murdered souls cannot find rest until justice is done, either through the murderer's death or divine judgment. Blood-soaked clothes are to be buried with the deceased rather than removed, based on the kabbalistic concept that the blood contains spiritual elements connected to the soul.

Regarding suicide, traditional Jewish practice treats this as a grave sin that affects burial procedures, though Ma'avar Yabok approaches this sensitive topic with notable compassion. While acknowledging the traditional view that suicides should be buried separately near the cemetery boundary, the text emphasizes the importance of determining whether the person acted with full awareness, suggesting that most suicides occur during states of extreme distress or mental disturbance that mitigate culpability. The text advocates for compassionate judgment, particularly for those who may have been suffering from what we would now recognize as mental illness.

For excommunicated persons (those under cherem), Ma'avar Yabok describes modified burial practices reflecting their separated status from the community. Such individuals were traditionally buried at a distance from others, with ritual stoning of their coffins paralleling the treatment of those sentenced to stoning execution in life. However, the text acknowledges the possibility of posthumous forgiveness and reconciliation, suggesting that proper burial rituals can help reintegrate the excommunicated person's soul into the community after death.

The text addresses cases where bodies are disfigured or incomplete, such as from accidents or warfare. In such situations, Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that every effort should be made to gather all body parts for burial, based on the kabbalistic understanding that the soul maintains connections to all parts of the body. When parts cannot be recovered, the text recommends modified rituals acknowledging the incompleteness while still providing all possible respect and dignity. The mystical concept of the luz bone (a small indestructible bone believed to be the nucleus for resurrection) receives particular attention, with the text emphasizing its importance for eventual bodily reconstitution.

For Torah scholars, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes special honors during burial preparations. The text instructs that scholars should be dressed with their written works placed alongside them, symbolizing their continued spiritual connection to Torah learning. Additional prayers and Psalms specific to scholars are recommended, acknowledging their elevated spiritual status. The book explains that Torah scholars enjoy special divine protection during the soul's journey after death, with angels escorting them to heavenly academies where they continue their studies in higher realms.

Regarding stillborn infants or children who died young, Ma'avar Yabok displays particular compassion. The text explains that while full burial rituals are performed,

with modified tahara appropriate to the child's size and age, these souls occupy a special elevated status in heaven. The book teaches that the souls of young children stand in a place "where even the completely righteous cannot ascend," and that their tears provide spiritual protection for the living. This compassionate theology offers comfort to grieving parents while providing guidance for proper ritual observance.

Finally, the text addresses the circumstances of those who die far from home or Jewish community. While emphasizing that proper Jewish burial is strongly preferred, Ma'avar Yabok acknowledges that circumstances sometimes make this impossible. In such cases, the text recommends specific prayers and intentions that can spiritually compensate for limitations in physical ritual observance. It explains that sincere prayers offered by distant family members can provide spiritual assistance to the deceased's soul even when traditional burial preparations cannot be fully performed.

The spiritual mechanics of soul transition

Throughout its detailed instructions for tahara and burial preparations, Ma'avar Yabok presents a sophisticated metaphysical framework explaining how these physical actions affect the soul's journey after death. This framework reveals the profound spiritual mechanics underlying Jewish burial practices, connecting seemingly mundane ritual actions to cosmic processes affecting multiple spiritual worlds.

Central to this framework is the understanding that the soul consists of multiple components that separate at death but maintain ongoing connections with each other and with the physical remains. Ma'avar Yabok describes a three-part structure consisting of nefesh (vital soul), ruach (spirit), and neshamah (higher soul), though occasionally it references additional components like chayah and yechidah that represent higher spiritual aspects. According to the text, these components experience different journeys after death: the nefesh remains near the grave, the ruach ascends to the lower Garden of Eden, and the neshamah reaches the upper Garden of Eden. However, these soul components maintain relationships with each other, especially during sacred times like Sabbath when they can temporarily reunite.

The text explains that proper burial preparations facilitate the separation and transition of these soul components, easing what would otherwise be a traumatic process. The washing rituals specifically address the nefesh component that remains most closely connected to the physical body, providing purification that removes negative spiritual attachments (described as "external forces" or "husks") that might otherwise impede its journey. The dressing in burial shrouds creates spiritual protection for the soul components as they navigate various spiritual realms, with different garments corresponding to different soul aspects.

Ma'avar Yabok presents a detailed timeline for the soul's journey after death that directly correlates with traditional mourning periods. During the first three days after death, the soul hovers near the body, which explains the text's emphasis on maintaining proper respect and dignity during this period. For seven days (corresponding to the shiva mourning period), the soul travels between its new spiritual dwelling and the grave before being allowed to appear before the Divine Presence. Over thirty days (sheloshim), the soul must ascend through thirty spiritual levels (ten in each of the three lower worlds) before reaching the highest world

of Atzilut (Emanation). This detailed timeline establishes a profound connection between mourning practices observed by the living and the actual spiritual journey experienced by the deceased's soul.

The text explains that proper burial practices create what it calls a "faithful shepherd" (ro'eh ne'eman) for the soul—a spiritual guide that assists its journey through various realms. This metaphorical shepherd consists of the mitzvot (commandments) performed by the deceased during life, combined with the proper ritual actions performed by the Chevra Kadisha and mourners. Together, these create a protective spiritual escort that guides the soul through judgment and toward its proper resting place.

Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that even after the soul components have reached their respective destinations, they maintain ongoing connections with the physical remains. The text describes a spiritual essence or "vital force" (ruach chiyut) that remains in the bones even after death, creating an enduring link between the physical remains and the soul's ongoing experience. This connection explains the importance of proper burial and the text's detailed instructions for treating the body with utmost respect throughout all preparations.

Of particular metaphysical importance is the pouring of nine measures of water during tahara, which the text explains in terms of divine unifications (yichudim) between different spiritual attributes. Ma'avar Yabok provides elaborate kabbalistic interpretations connecting this ritual to the ten sefirot (divine emanations), suggesting that the flowing water creates channels between Chesed (Loving-kindness) and Din (Judgment) that help transform harsh spiritual judgment into mercy. This transformation directly benefits the soul during its judgment process after death.

The text presents burial preparations as creating cosmic repairs (tikkunim) that extend far beyond the individual soul being prepared. Proper rituals are understood to affect multiple spiritual worlds, helping to restore divine harmony disrupted by death. The washing rituals specifically create what the text calls "sweetening of judgments" (mitak ha-dinim), a kabbalistic concept referring to the transformation of divine severity into mercy. This cosmic process benefits not only the deceased but the entire world, as it helps maintain proper balance between divine attributes.

Ma'avar Yabok explicitly connects burial preparations to the ultimate resurrection of the dead, suggesting that proper treatment of the body facilitates its eventual reconstitution. The text describes how the luz bone—a small, indestructible bone believed to be located either at the base of the skull or at the bottom of the spine—serves as the nucleus for resurrection, maintaining a physical anchor for the soul's eventual return. The burial garments are similarly understood as preparation for resurrection, creating spiritual patterns that will help reconstitute the body when the time comes.

The spiritual mechanics presented in Ma'avar Yabok reveal burial preparations as far more than respectful disposition of physical remains. These rituals constitute a sophisticated spiritual technology that actively shapes the soul's posthumous experience, provides protection during its journey through various realms, facilitates its judgment and purification, and prepares it for eventual resurrection. This metaphysical framework transforms seemingly simple ritual actions—washing, pouring water, dressing in shrouds—into cosmic interventions with profound spiritual consequences extending across multiple worlds and dimensions of existence.

The enduring wisdom of Tahara

The tahara and burial preparation practices described in Ma'avar Yabok represent a remarkable integration of practical compassion and sophisticated mystical understanding. Far from being mere cultural customs, these rituals emerge from the text as a comprehensive spiritual system addressing the complex needs of both body and soul during the critical transition of death. This system reflects core Jewish values—dignity, equality, community responsibility, and hope for ultimate redemption—while providing practical guidance for those engaged in the sacred work of preparing the dead for burial.

What distinguishes Ma'avar Yabok's approach is its consistent integration of practical instructions with profound metaphysical explanations. Each physical action is presented as simultaneously addressing practical necessity and cosmic purpose, creating a seamless connection between mundane and spiritual realms. This integration transforms what might otherwise be seen as simple hygienic procedures into sacred rituals with far-reaching spiritual effects. The washing of the body becomes purification of the soul; the dressing in shrouds becomes preparation for resurrection; the careful handling of physical remains becomes protection for the departing spirit.

The text's emphasis on kavvanah (proper intention) throughout burial preparations highlights the importance of consciousness in ritual practice. According to Ma'avar Yabok, the effectiveness of these rituals depends not merely on correct physical actions but on the spiritual awareness and intention of those performing them. This principle elevates the work of the Chevra Kadisha beyond mechanical procedure to sacred service requiring both physical skill and spiritual understanding. It suggests that proper burial preparation involves a contemplative dimension—an awareness of one's role in facilitating cosmic processes that extend far beyond the visible world.

Ma'avar Yabok's detailed explanations of the soul's journey after death provide powerful comfort to the bereaved by presenting death not as an ending but as a transition. The text offers a coherent vision of continued existence, purposeful judgment, and ultimate resurrection that places individual death within a meaningful cosmic framework. The elaborate description of how proper burial preparations aid this journey transforms grief into sacred action, allowing mourners to actively participate in assisting their loved one's soul rather than feeling helpless in the face of death.

The consistent emphasis on treating all deceased with equal dignity regardless of status or circumstances reflects core Jewish ethical values. Ma'avar Yabok's instructions for simple white burial garments, its prohibition against excessive ornamentation, and its insistence on the same basic ritual procedures for all (with modifications only as specifically required) establish death as the great equalizer. This equality in death serves as a powerful reminder of human commonality transcending social distinctions, wealth disparities, and other worldly differences.

Perhaps most profoundly, the text presents tahara and burial preparations as part of an ongoing covenant relationship between the living and the dead. The careful attention given to the deceased creates spiritual benefits that flow in both directions: the deceased's soul receives assistance in its journey, while those performing these sacred duties accumulate spiritual merit. This reciprocal relationship

extends beyond the immediate burial society to include the entire community, establishing care for the dead as a communal responsibility with communal benefits.

The wisdom preserved in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to tahara and burial preparations transcends its historical context, offering insights relevant to contemporary questions about dignity in death, the relationship between physical and spiritual care, and the importance of meaningful ritual in confronting mortality. Its sophisticated integration of practical compassion with metaphysical understanding continues to inspire and guide Jewish burial societies centuries after its composition, ensuring that those who have completed their earthly journey receive proper care as they transition to the next world—crossing their own spiritual Yabok River with dignity, respect, and hope for what lies beyond.

Appendix H

The Garden of Eden and Gehenna

The Jewish understanding of the afterlife represents one of the most nuanced and complex eschatological systems in world religions, distinctly different from both the Christian binary of heaven and hell and the Eastern concepts of rebirth and karma. The Jewish afterlife tradition developed gradually, with relatively sparse references in the Hebrew Bible evolving into elaborate cosmological systems by the medieval period. This evolution reached its zenith in kabbalistic works like the Zohar and later texts such as Aaron Berechia of Modena's *Ma'avar Yabok* (Crossing of the Jabbok), which present intricate descriptions of the soul's journey after death.

Unlike traditions that emphasize eternal punishment or reward, Jewish mystical thought conceives of the afterlife primarily as a complex process of spiritual refinement and elevation. The soul, having completed its earthly sojourn, embarks on a journey through various realms designed not merely to reward or punish, but to purify, rectify, and ultimately prepare it for higher spiritual states. This perspective reflects Judaism's characteristic emphasis on this-worldly actions and responsibilities, while still acknowledging the soul's continued existence and development after physical death.

The Garden of Eden (Gan Eden) and Gehenna (Gehinnom) constitute the two primary spiritual realms of this afterlife journey. However, contrary to simplistic heaven/hell dichotomies, these realms function as complementary stations in the soul's progress rather than permanent destinations. Gan Eden represents not merely a reward but a complex spiritual ecosystem with multiple levels, chambers, and palaces, where souls experience divine delight proportionate to their spiritual attainments. Conversely, Gehenna serves not as eternal damnation but as a temporary realm of purification where souls confront and cleanse themselves of spiritual impurities accumulated during physical existence.

The development of these concepts reflects broader trends in Jewish religious thought—an increasing preoccupation with individual spiritual destiny alongside communal covenant, a deepening interest in cosmic structures and correspondences, and a commitment to harmonizing justice with mercy in understanding divine governance. The systematic elaboration of afterlife geography in texts like *Ma'avar Yabok* also demonstrates the Jewish tendency to organize spiritual realities according to

hierarchical structures that reflect divine attributes and cosmic principles.

What makes the Jewish mystical approach to the afterlife particularly distinctive is its integration of seemingly contradictory elements: individual judgment with universal salvation, temporal punishment with eternal spiritual progress, divine justice with divine mercy, and embodied existence with disembodied spiritual states. These tensions are not viewed as contradictions but as complementary aspects of a complex divine system designed to bring all creation, including human souls, to their ultimate perfection.

This appendix explores these afterlife realms as presented in Jewish mystical literature, with particular attention to the detailed descriptions found in *Ma'avar Yabok*. The cosmic geography of Gan Eden and Gehenna reveals much about how Jewish mystics understood the relationship between divine justice and mercy, the purpose of human existence, and the ultimate destiny of the soul. Through this exploration, we gain insight not only into traditional Jewish beliefs about what happens after death but also into the profound ethical and spiritual principles that inform Jewish approaches to life itself.

The Garden of Eden: cosmic geography

In Jewish mystical tradition, the Garden of Eden (Gan Eden) represents far more than the biblical paradise from which Adam and Eve were expelled. It constitutes an elaborate spiritual realm with distinct cosmic functions and a complex internal geography. According to kabbalistic works like the Zohar and *Ma'avar Yabok*, Gan Eden exists simultaneously on multiple planes of reality, serving as both the destination for righteous souls after death and a cosmic nexus where divine energies flow between spiritual worlds.

The foundational distinction in kabbalistic thought is between the "Lower Garden of Eden" (Gan Eden HaTachton) and the "Upper Garden of Eden" (Gan Eden HaElyon). This distinction corresponds to the broader kabbalistic framework of the four worlds: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action). The Lower Garden resides within the world of Yetzirah (Formation), while the Upper Garden exists within Beriah (Creation). These placements are significant because they establish the Gardens as intermediate realms between the purely spiritual world of divine emanation (Atzilut) and the physical world of action (Asiyah).

Ma'avar Yabok elaborates on this structure by explaining that "Eden" and "Garden" actually represent distinct but interconnected elements. Eden itself (typically associated with Binah, the divine attribute of Understanding) represents the source, while the Garden (associated with Malkhut, the divine attribute of Sovereignty) represents the recipient of Eden's flow. As the text states: "The Garden of earth and heaven receives from Eden, which is the source of the springs of wisdom." This relationship mirrors the kabbalistic principle of masculine and feminine energies, with Eden providing the spiritual "seed" that flourishes in the receptive "soil" of the Garden.

The Lower Garden of Eden contains numerous chambers (heikhalot) organized in concentric circles, each corresponding to different levels of spiritual attainment and housing souls of varying degrees of merit. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes these chambers

in detail, noting that "there are seven palaces in the Lower Garden, and similarly, seven in the Upper Garden, each more glorious than the other." The outermost chambers house souls of minimal merit, while the innermost sanctums are reserved for the most spiritually advanced. This architectural arrangement establishes a spatial hierarchy that reflects moral and spiritual distinctions, with proximity to the center indicating greater spiritual achievement.

Each chamber contains specific categories of righteous souls, organized according to their primary virtues. There are designated areas for martyrs who sanctified God's name, for scholars who devoted themselves to Torah study, for those who suffered during life but maintained their faith, for those who educated children in righteousness, and for those who transformed their communities through acts of kindness. This organization reflects the Jewish emphasis on diverse paths to righteousness, suggesting that various forms of spiritual excellence receive appropriate recognition in the afterlife.

A defining feature of the Garden's cosmic geography is the "River of Light" that flows from the Upper Garden to nourish the Lower Garden. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes this river as "emerging from Eden to water the garden," drawing on the biblical description in Genesis but interpreting it as a channel for divine energy rather than literal water. This river serves multiple functions: it nourishes the souls residing in the Garden, it facilitates communication between different levels of the afterlife, and it symbolizes the continuous flow of divine blessing from higher realms to lower ones.

The Garden's internal landscape features not only palaces but also fields, orchards, and mountains, each with symbolic significance. The "Field of Sacred Apples" (Chakal Tapuchin Kadishin) represents the divine feminine presence (Shekhinah), while the mountains symbolize the higher sefirot (divine attributes). These geographical features are not merely decorative but functional, serving as locations for specific spiritual activities. Souls gather in the fields to receive new teachings, ascend the mountains to perceive divine revelations, and enjoy the fruits of the orchards as a form of spiritual sustenance.

Central to the Garden's cosmic purpose is its function as a dwelling place for the Shekhinah (Divine Presence). *Ma'avar Yabok* states that "the Shekhinah dwells in the Garden at fixed times, especially at midnight and during sacred occasions." This indwelling transforms the Garden from merely a pleasant abode for righteous souls into a sacred space where divine revelation continues after death. The cyclical presence of the Shekhinah creates a temporal rhythm within the Garden, with souls experiencing heightened states of spiritual ecstasy during these divine visitations.

The Garden also contains a central pillar (sometimes called the "Tree of Life") that extends from the lowest realms to the highest, providing a pathway for souls to ascend to higher levels. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, "righteous souls may ascend this pathway on Sabbaths and festivals," temporarily experiencing more elevated states of consciousness before returning to their designated chambers. This vertical mobility introduces a dynamic element to the Garden's structure, allowing souls to progress spiritually even after death rather than remaining static in assigned positions.

The Garden's relationship to Jerusalem represents another significant aspect of its cosmic geography. *Ma'avar Yabok* asserts that "the Garden of Eden is situated directly above earthly Jerusalem, and the gate of the Garden aligns with the Temple

Mount." This correspondence establishes a vertical axis connecting sacred spaces across multiple worlds, suggesting that the Temple service on earth had direct effects on spiritual realms above. Consequently, even after the Temple's destruction, prayers offered at the Western Wall were believed to ascend directly to the Garden's gate.

The landscape of Gan Eden is not merely beautiful but instructive, containing what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "chambers of wisdom" where souls continue their spiritual education. These chambers contain scrolls of celestial fire on which divine teachings are inscribed, allowing souls to study ever-deeper layers of Torah that were inaccessible during physical life. This educational function reflects the Jewish valuation of knowledge as a spiritual good, suggesting that intellectual growth continues in the afterlife rather than being replaced by passive bliss.

For the kabbalists, the Garden of Eden represents not just a posthumous reward but a cosmic reality that influences and is influenced by human actions. Righteous deeds in the physical world create "aromatic scents" in the Garden, while Torah study opens new "wellsprings" that nourish its landscape. This reciprocal relationship ensures that the Garden is not a static paradise but a dynamic spiritual ecosystem that responds to human spiritual achievements and contributes to the ultimate perfection of creation.

The Upper and Lower Gardens

The distinction between the Upper and Lower Gardens of Eden represents more than a spatial differentiation; it reflects a profound understanding of the soul's progressive spiritual journey through increasingly refined states of consciousness. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, this division corresponds to the kabbalistic understanding of the soul's components, with the Ruach (spirit) dwelling in the Lower Garden and the Neshamah (higher soul) ascending to the Upper Garden, while the Nefesh (vital soul) remains connected to the grave.

The Lower Garden of Eden, situated in the World of Yetzirah (Formation), provides an intermediate experience that maintains some connection to embodied existence. Here, souls appear in forms resembling their earthly bodies, though composed of more refined spiritual substance. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes these forms as "spiritual garments woven from the light generated by their mitzvot [commandments]." These garments allow souls to recognize one another and maintain a sense of individual identity while experiencing a more elevated existence than was possible during physical life.

Activities in the Lower Garden retain analogues to earthly experience, though transformed into purely spiritual expressions. Souls "eat" by absorbing the radiance of the Divine Presence, "drink" from rivers of divine light, and "converse" through direct thought-communication rather than physical speech. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, "They delight in the splendor of the Shekhinah and partake of the spiritual sustenance that flows from the supernal table." This mode of existence provides continuity with earthly life while elevating its pleasures to a spiritual plane.

Social structures within the Lower Garden reflect earthly relationships transformed by spiritual principles. Souls gather in "assemblies" (yeshivot) organized around great sages, studying together and sharing insights. Family relationships

persist but are reorganized according to spiritual affinity rather than merely biological connection. *Ma'avar Yabok* notes that "a son who exceeded his father in righteousness may occupy a higher chamber, though he will still honor his father according to the commandment." This arrangement balances respect for familial bonds with recognition of individual spiritual achievement.

The Upper Garden of Eden, located in the World of Beriah (Creation), represents a more profound departure from embodied experience. Here, souls shed their resemblance to physical forms and exist as "pure intellectual lights," directly perceiving divine truths without the mediation of images or metaphors. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes this state as "cleaving to the supernal light without any intervening barrier," a level of immediate divine communion impossible even in the Lower Garden. The pleasure experienced in this realm is described as "intellectual delight," the joy of direct comprehension of divine wisdom.

The architecture of the Upper Garden reflects its more abstract nature. Instead of palaces and fields, it contains what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "chambers of primordial light" and "treasuries of divine wisdom." These structures are not spatial in any conventional sense but represent different qualities of divine illumination. The text describes souls in this realm as "encircled by the splendor of the divine crown," experiencing direct exposure to divine attributes that would overwhelm souls of lesser spiritual capacity.

Communication in the Upper Garden transcends even the thought-transfer of the Lower Garden, occurring through what kabbalists call "kissing of spirits" (neshikin de-ruchin)—a complete interpenetration of consciousness whereby souls share understanding without any differentiation between transmitter and receiver. *Ma'avar Yabok* states that in this realm, "souls communicate through the unification of intellectual lights, each illuminating the other without diminishment." This mode of communion represents the perfection of interpersonal connection, entirely free from the misunderstandings and boundaries that characterize earthly communication.

The relationship between the Upper and Lower Gardens involves complex patterns of movement and visitation. While most souls cannot permanently ascend from the Lower to the Upper Garden until they have completed their purification, temporary ascents occur during sacred times. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, "On Sabbaths and festivals, the gates between the Gardens open, allowing souls from below to ascend and glimpse higher revelations." This cyclical pattern creates a temporal rhythm in the afterlife that mirrors the Jewish calendar, suggesting that sacred time maintains its significance beyond physical existence.

Ma'avar Yabok also describes how souls in both Gardens benefit from prayers and good deeds performed by the living. When descendants study Torah or perform mitzvot in memory of the deceased, these actions create "channels of light" that convey additional spiritual sustenance to the souls in both Gardens. The text states that "when children recite Kaddish [the mourner's prayer], their words ascend like a crown upon their parents' souls, elevating them to higher chambers." This ongoing connection between the living and the dead ensures that relationships continue to evolve even across the boundary of physical death.

The ultimate purpose of both Gardens extends beyond reward for past deeds to preparation for future cosmic developments. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that "souls gather in the Gardens to prepare for the World to Come and the resurrection, when they will return to their bodies in a transformed state." This perspective frames the

afterlife experience not as an end but as an intermediate phase in the soul's ongoing journey toward perfect existence in both spiritual and physical dimensions. The Gardens function as training grounds where souls develop the spiritual capacities necessary for this future perfected state.

Gehenna: origin, structure, and function

Gehenna (Gehinnom) represents one of the most frequently misunderstood concepts in Jewish eschatology, often incorrectly equated with the Christian concept of Hell as a place of eternal punishment. In Jewish mystical thought, particularly as elaborated in *Ma'avar Yabok*, Gehenna serves primarily as a realm of spiritual purification rather than punitive suffering. Its existence reflects not divine vengeance but divine mercy, providing souls with the opportunity to cleanse themselves of impurities that would prevent their ultimate elevation.

The cosmic origin of Gehenna reveals its fundamental purpose within divine creation. According to kabbalistic teachings cited in *Ma'avar Yabok*, Gehenna was created on the second day of creation—the only day about which Scripture does not say "and God saw that it was good." This timing indicates that Gehenna represents a necessary but temporary aspect of creation, essential for cosmic balance but not part of creation's final perfected state. The text states that "Gehenna was formed from the divine attribute of Judgment (Din) when it operated in isolation from Mercy (Rachamim)," suggesting that it embodies a circumscribed and balanced expression of divine severity rather than unchecked punitive power.

Physically, Gehenna is located in what kabbalists call "Arka," one of the seven earths in the kabbalistic cosmography. *Ma'avar Yabok* places it specifically "in the northwest, in the place of darkness and shadow," symbolically distant from Jerusalem (associated with the southeast and divine light). This geographical positioning reflects Gehenna's spiritual function as the realm furthest removed from direct divine illumination, where souls experience the consequences of their estrangement from divine connection.

The structural organization of Gehenna follows a sevenfold pattern, with distinct levels or "chambers" designed to address different categories of spiritual impurity. *Ma'avar Yabok* details these seven departments:

1. Sheol: For those who committed sins of pride and arrogance
2. Abaddon: For those who led others astray through false teachings
3. Be'er Shachat: For those who profaned sacred matters
4. Tit HaYaven: For those who slandered and spoke maliciously
5. Tzalmavet: For those who stole from the poor or committed sexual transgressions
6. Sha'arei Mavet: For those who took pleasure in others' suffering
7. Gehinnom proper: For those who harbored hatred without cause

Each level contains specific conditions and purification processes designed to address the particular spiritual damage created by its corresponding category of sin. These conditions are not arbitrary punishments but reflect the natural consequences of the soul's own actions, allowing direct experiential recognition of the harm caused by various transgressions.

Contrary to popular misconceptions, Gehenna is administered not by demons or devils but by angels fulfilling divine functions. *Ma'avar Yabok* identifies Dumah ("Silence") as the principal angelic overseer of Gehenna, assisted by angels called "Masters of Judgment" who ensure that purification processes precisely match each soul's specific needs. These angels do not take pleasure in suffering but function as spiritual physicians, administering difficult but necessary treatments to heal the soul's self-inflicted wounds.

The purification process in Gehenna operates through what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "fire of the soul" rather than material flame. This spiritual fire represents the soul's own recognition of its failings when exposed to divine truth—a painful but illuminating process of self-judgment. The text explains that "the soul itself becomes the fire and the fuel" as it confronts the full consequences of its actions without the defensive mechanisms that obscured these consequences during physical life. This self-generated nature of the purification process reflects the kabbalistic principle that divine judgment ultimately aims at restoration rather than destruction.

Temporally, Gehenna operates according to precise cosmic schedules that reflect divine mercy. Standard duration of purification is limited to twelve months, based on the rabbinic teaching that "the judgment of the wicked in Gehenna lasts twelve months." *Ma'avar Yabok* emphasizes that "even the greatest sinners, except for a small minority who severed themselves entirely from divine connection, experience only temporary purification." This temporal limitation underscores the rehabilitative rather than punitive purpose of Gehenna, contrasting sharply with concepts of eternal damnation found in some other religious traditions.

The severity and duration of the purification process varies according to several factors. Souls that performed mitzvot and acts of kindness during life receive periods of respite from purification. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, "Those who observed the Sabbath properly are released from Gehenna every Sabbath," while "those who performed charity with proper intention receive regular intervals of relief." These temporary reprieves reflect the principle that good deeds create genuine spiritual merit that persists even when the soul requires purification in other areas.

Gehenna also includes specific "cooling chambers" where souls recover between periods of purification. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes these as "places of respite where angels of mercy attend to souls and prepare them for the next stage of their purification." This alternation between intensive purification and recovery periods allows souls to integrate the lessons of each phase before proceeding to the next, preventing overwhelming experiences that might impede rather than facilitate spiritual progress.

An important feature of Gehenna described in *Ma'avar Yabok* is the "River of Fire" (Nehar Dinur) that all souls must cross as part of their transition to higher realms. This river, composed of "the intellectual fire generated by the debates of the heavenly academy," serves as both barrier and gateway. Souls that retain significant impurities cannot cross this river until they have undergone sufficient purification, while those who have completed their cleansing process pass through

it safely, finding that its fire acts as the final purifying agent that prepares them for entry into the Garden of Eden.

The experience of purification in Gehenna is not uniform but carefully calibrated to each soul's specific needs. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that "each soul encounters precisely the aspects of Gehenna necessary for its particular rectification." Some require brief, intense purification in multiple chambers, while others need prolonged but gentler processing in a single department. This individualized approach reflects the kabbalistic understanding that divine judgment operates with perfect precision, addressing exactly the areas where each soul requires correction.

Remarkably, *Ma'avar Yabok* describes how righteous souls occasionally enter Gehenna voluntarily—not for their own purification but to rescue others. Drawing on Talmudic and Zoharic sources, the text states that "our father Abraham stands at the entrance to Gehenna and rescues all who observed the covenant of circumcision," while other righteous individuals similarly intercede for those with whom they share spiritual connections. This redemptive activity illustrates the Jewish concept that souls remain connected in a community of responsibility even after death.

Perhaps most significantly, *Ma'avar Yabok* emphasizes that Gehenna itself will ultimately be transformed. Citing the Zohar, it states that "in the future time, the Holy One will transform Gehenna into a garden of delight." This eschatological perspective reveals that even the realm of purification belongs to the divine plan for universal restoration rather than standing outside it. Gehenna exists not as divine creation's failure but as a temporary but necessary phase in its perfection.

The soul's journey: from death to resurrection

The soul's posthumous journey as described in *Ma'avar Yabok* follows a meticulously structured itinerary with distinct phases, each serving specific spiritual functions. This journey begins not at the moment of death but slightly before it, as the soul begins a gradual process of separation from the body. According to the text, "thirty days before death, certain aspects of the soul begin to withdraw during sleep," a process that intensifies as death approaches. This gradual withdrawal explains deathbed visions and premonitions experienced by many individuals, as their partially-detached souls gain access to spiritual perceptions normally blocked by full embodiment.

The actual moment of death represents what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "the kiss of separation" (neshikat preidah) for most individuals, though the most righteous experience "the kiss of unity" (neshikat yichud)—a direct divine embrace that draws the soul upward without the anxiety that typically accompanies the separation process. For ordinary souls, angels assist in the separation, with the Angel of Death performing the final severance while angels of mercy stand ready to receive the departing soul. The text emphasizes that proper deathbed rituals, particularly recitation of the Shema prayer and confession (vidui), can significantly ease this transition by creating protective spiritual environments.

Immediately following death, the soul enters a state of confusion as it adjusts to disembodied existence. During this period, it remains near the body, aware of everything said and done in its presence. *Ma'avar Yabok* cautions that "one should speak only good things near the deceased, as the soul hears and is affected by all

that is said." This initial phase typically lasts until burial, which explains the Jewish emphasis on prompt interment—not only for hygiene reasons but to allow the soul to begin its onward journey without unnecessary delay.

The first formal judgment occurs through what Jewish tradition calls Chibut HaKever (the Beating of the Grave), a process that begins immediately after burial. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes this as "the separation of remaining impurities that cling to the soul from its physical existence." This process affects the Nefesh (vital soul), the lowest component of the soul structure that remains most closely connected to physical existence. During Chibut HaKever, angels question the soul about its lifetime actions, particularly regarding Torah study and ethical conduct. For the righteous, this questioning is gentle and brief, while for others, it may involve more intensive processes of self-confrontation.

Following this initial purification, the soul's components begin their separate journeys. The Nefesh remains near the grave for twelve months, gradually detaching from bodily identity. The Ruach (spirit) ascends to be judged at the entrance to the Lower Garden of Eden, potentially requiring a period in Gehenna before admission. The Neshamah (higher soul), if sufficiently pure, ascends directly to the Upper Garden. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that "these soul components remain connected through subtle threads of light," maintaining the soul's essential unity despite their different locations.

For souls requiring purification, the journey through Gehenna follows specific protocols. Upon entering, each soul undergoes an assessment to determine which aspects require cleansing and in which chambers this process should occur. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes how "angels of judgment measure the soul against the actions of its lifetime," creating a precise remediation plan. The soul then proceeds through its assigned chambers, experiencing purification tailored to address its specific spiritual blemishes. This process typically lasts a maximum of twelve months, though Sabbaths and festivals provide regular intervals of respite.

After completing purification, souls must cross the River of Fire (Nehar Dinur), which serves as both final purifier and gateway to the Garden of Eden. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes this crossing as "momentarily painful but ultimately healing," as the river's flames burn away any remaining impurities while leaving the essential soul intact. Once across, the soul receives new spiritual garments woven from the light of its good deeds and Torah study, with the quality and luminosity of these garments reflecting its spiritual achievements.

Upon entering the Lower Garden of Eden, the soul undergoes a period of orientation, guided by appointed angels who explain the Garden's structure and the soul's designated place within it. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes how "each soul is led to the chamber corresponding to its highest achievement," whether that involves Torah scholarship, acts of kindness, martyrdom, or other forms of spiritual excellence. The soul then begins to experience the Garden's delights, particularly the radiance of the Divine Presence that shines throughout this realm.

For souls with sufficient merit, the journey continues through periodic ascents to higher levels. On Sabbaths, festivals, and new moons, the gates between the Lower and Upper Gardens open, allowing worthy souls to temporarily experience more elevated states of consciousness. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that "souls that have completed their purification may eventually ascend permanently to the Upper Garden," where they experience direct intellectual communion with divine wisdom

rather than the more tangible spiritual pleasures of the Lower Garden.

Throughout this journey, souls maintain connections with other souls based on shared spiritual missions, familial relationships, and teacher-student bonds. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes heavenly academies where souls gather around great sages, continuing their study of Torah at increasingly profound levels. In these academies, "questions that remained unresolved in earthly study find their answers," and souls gain access to deeper dimensions of wisdom that were inaccessible during physical life.

The journey also includes ongoing relationships with the living. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains how "souls are aware of their descendants' actions and prayers," and can intercede on behalf of the living during times of need. When descendants recite Kaddish, study Torah, or perform charitable acts in memory of the deceased, these actions create "channels of light" that nourish the soul and may elevate it to higher chambers. This reciprocal relationship allows meaningful connections to continue across the boundary between life and death.

For most souls, this afterlife journey is not permanent but represents an intermediate state awaiting the ultimate resurrection. *Ma'avar Yabok* describes how "at the time of resurrection, souls will descend to reclaim their purified bodies," which will have been transformed into more spiritual vessels capable of containing the soul's elevated consciousness. This return to embodied existence represents not a regression but a perfection, uniting the advantages of spiritual perception with the capacity for physical action in a transformed world.

Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that this entire journey—from deathbed to resurrection—can be positively influenced by proper preparation during life. Regular Torah study, ethical conduct, charitable giving, and spiritual practices create both merit for the soul and familiarity with spiritual realities that ease the post-mortem transition. The text states that "one who has accustomed themselves to holiness during life will naturally gravitate toward holiness after death," suggesting that the afterlife journey represents a continuation and fulfillment of patterns established during physical existence rather than an entirely new beginning.

The relationship between the living and the dead

One of the most distinctive aspects of the Jewish mystical understanding of the afterlife is the ongoing, reciprocal relationship it posits between the living and the dead. Far from depicting the deceased as entirely separated from the world of the living, *Ma'avar Yabok* presents an intricate system of interactions through which actions in one realm directly affect experiences in the other. This interconnectedness creates a community that transcends the boundary of physical death, allowing relationships to continue evolving rather than terminating at the grave.

For the living, numerous ritual actions can benefit departed souls. Chief among these is the recitation of Kaddish, the mourner's prayer, which *Ma'avar Yabok* describes as "creating a crown of light that adorns the soul of the deceased and helps elevate it to higher chambers." The efficacy of Kaddish derives not merely from its words but from its public nature—it requires a minyan (quorum of ten) and thus embeds the act of remembrance within community, reflecting the Jewish

emphasis on collective spiritual responsibility.

Torah study performed in memory of the deceased similarly creates what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "channels of illumination" that directly nourish the soul in its posthumous state. The text explains that "when children or students study Torah and attribute their insights to their departed parent or teacher, these insights ascend to the heavenly academy and are announced as coming from the deceased's lineage." This attribution creates not only benefit for the departed soul but a continuing intellectual legacy that transcends physical mortality.

Charitable giving represents another powerful means through which the living assist the dead. *Ma'avar Yabok* states that "when charity is given in memory of the deceased, with explicit mention of their name, this creates merit that can reduce their time in Gehenna or elevate them to higher chambers in the Garden." The efficacy of this practice is enhanced when the recipients of charity themselves acknowledge its purpose, creating a three-way relationship between donor, recipient, and the soul being commemorated.

Prayer at gravesites establishes direct communication with departed souls. According to *Ma'avar Yabok*, "when one visits a grave and addresses the deceased directly, the soul is immediately notified and descends to that location to hear the prayer." This practice functions not as necromancy (forbidden in Jewish tradition) but as a means of requesting the soul's intercession before the divine throne. The text recommends specific prayers for these visits, emphasizing that they should focus on asking the deceased to advocate for the living rather than attempting to communicate with the dead for guidance or information.

The Yahrzeit (anniversary of death) observance creates what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "a day of judgment and elevation for the soul." On this date, the soul undergoes an annual assessment, potentially advancing to higher levels based on a combination of its own spiritual progress and the merit generated by descendants' commemorative actions. The text recommends specific practices for Yahrzeits, including studying Mishnah chapters corresponding to the letters of the deceased's name, lighting a memorial candle, and giving additional charity.

From the perspective of the deceased, souls retain awareness of and concern for their living descendants. *Ma'avar Yabok* states that "souls in the Garden of Eden are regularly informed about significant events affecting their families," including births, marriages, illnesses, and achievements. This ongoing connection allows departed souls to experience continued nachat (pride and pleasure) from their descendants' positive actions, creating a multi-generational spiritual continuity.

More actively, departed souls function as what *Ma'avar Yabok* calls "advocates in the celestial court" (meilitzei yosher) on behalf of their descendants. The text explains that "when a person faces difficulty or danger, the souls of their ancestors immediately gather before the divine throne to plead their case." This advocacy is particularly powerful during times of communal crisis, when the collective merit of previous generations can be invoked to mitigate harsh divine judgments against the community.

Ma'avar Yabok specifically notes that righteous souls "descend from the Garden of Eden to attend family celebrations," particularly circumcisions, weddings, and significant Torah study gatherings. Though invisible to ordinary perception, these souls participate in these events and derive pleasure from witnessing the continuation of religious traditions across generations. The text cites kabbalistic sources

describing a special chair (kisei shel Eliyahu) reserved for the prophet Elijah at circumcision ceremonies, which symbolizes this ongoing presence of departed souls at significant family milestones.

Dreams serve as a particular channel through which the dead may communicate with the living. *Ma'avar Yabok* states that "when a person dreams of a deceased relative delivering a message, this may represent genuine communication, especially if the message concerns Torah matters or ethical guidance." The text provides criteria for distinguishing authentic posthumous communications from ordinary dreams, emphasizing that genuine messages never contradict Torah teachings and typically address matters of spiritual rather than material concern.

Significantly, this reciprocal relationship extends beyond family connections to include teacher-student bonds and communal affiliations. *Ma'avar Yabok* explains that "the souls of great sages continue to teach and guide their students from the heavenly academy," sometimes inspiring new insights that the living scholar attributes to the influence of their departed teacher. Similarly, communities benefit from the ongoing advocacy of the righteous individuals who once lived among them, creating a form of posthumous spiritual leadership that complements living authorities.

The ultimate expression of this reciprocal relationship will occur at the resurrection, when according to *Ma'avar Yabok*, "souls will return to transformed bodies, bringing with them the wisdom and spiritual attainments acquired in the afterlife." This event represents not merely a restoration of previous existence but an elevation, as the accumulated spiritual achievements of both the living and the dead contribute to creating a perfected world in which physical and spiritual realms achieve full integration.

This elaborate system of continued relationship between the living and the dead reflects Judaism's characteristic emphasis on covenant, community, and intergenerational responsibility. Unlike traditions that emphasize complete separation between this world and the next, Jewish mystical thought as presented in *Ma'avar Yabok* portrays a cosmic order in which all souls—embodied and disembodied—participate in an ongoing project of tikkun olam (world repair) that transcends the boundaries of physical existence and death.

The afterlife as spiritual process

The Jewish mystical conception of the afterlife, as elaborated in texts like *Ma'avar Yabok*, presents a vision of cosmic justice and spiritual development that differs markedly from simplistic notions of eternal reward and punishment. Instead of static destinations, Gan Eden and Gehenna function as complementary phases in an ongoing process of spiritual refinement that ultimately serves the divine purpose of universal elevation and perfection.

This process-oriented understanding reflects Judaism's characteristic emphasis on covenant rather than creed, action rather than belief, and spiritual growth rather than final states. The afterlife journey described in *Ma'avar Yabok* accommodates the full spectrum of human spiritual conditions while affirming the ultimate value of every soul, providing pathways for purification and elevation appropriate to each individual's specific needs and capacities.

The complex structures of both Gan Eden and Gehenna reveal a cosmic order governed by principles of precise spiritual causality rather than arbitrary reward and punishment. Each soul experiences exactly the consequences of its own actions, with divine judgment operating not as external imposition but as the natural unfolding of spiritual laws built into creation itself. This understanding transforms the fearful prospect of judgment into an opportunity for recognition, rectification, and growth.

Perhaps most significantly, the reciprocal relationship between the living and the dead demonstrates that the community of Israel extends beyond the boundaries of physical existence, creating an unbroken chain of spiritual responsibility and care that spans generations and worlds. This perspective offers profound comfort to the bereaved while also enhancing the meaning of religious observance, which acquires transgenerational significance through its effects across multiple planes of existence.

For the modern reader, these elaborate afterlife cosmologies may initially seem fantastical or antiquated. However, when understood as metaphorical expressions of profound spiritual and ethical principles, they continue to offer valuable insights about human purpose, divine justice, and the ultimate meaning of existence. The vision of an afterlife that honors individual achievement while working toward universal restoration speaks to perennial human concerns about personal significance and cosmic justice.

Ma'avar Yabok's detailed expositions of Gan Eden and Gehenna ultimately serve not merely to satisfy curiosity about what happens after death but to guide and inspire religious life in the present. By understanding the cosmic significance of everyday ethical choices and spiritual practices, the individual can approach life with greater intentionality and purpose, recognizing that each action contributes to an ongoing process of personal and universal transformation that transcends the boundaries of physical existence and extends into eternity.

Appendix I

Prayer and Incense (Ketoret)

In Jewish thought, prayer occupies a unique position as both a spiritual exercise and a ritual substitute for Temple worship following the destruction of the Second Temple in 70 CE. Rabbi Aaron Berechia of Modena's *Ma'avar Yabok* exemplifies this substitutive theological approach, particularly in its fourth discourse, "Eter Anan HaKetoret" (The Cloud of Incense Prayer). This section develops a sophisticated framework where prayers, properly articulated, create the same metaphysical effects as the physical sacrifices and incense offerings once performed in the Jerusalem Temple.

The title "Eter Anan HaKetoret" itself encapsulates this theology, combining "eter" (prayer/supplication), "anan" (cloud), and "ketoret" (incense) to evoke the image of prayers ascending like incense smoke to the divine presence. This metaphor finds its biblical basis in Psalm 141:2, "May my prayer be set before You as incense, the lifting of my hands as the evening sacrifice," a verse frequently cited throughout the text. For Aaron Berechia, this is not merely poetic imagery but a concrete metaphysical reality—properly formulated prayers actually function as spiritual incense, creating the same cosmic effects as the Temple service.

The theological framework underpinning this substitution draws from rabbinic teachings about the purpose of prayer after the Temple's destruction. The Talmudic sages declared, "Now that we have no sacrifices, prayer stands in their place," establishing prayer as not merely a compensatory activity but a true ritual replacement. Aaron Berechia expands this concept through kabbalistic principles, explaining that speech creates tangible spiritual entities through the power of the twenty-two Hebrew letters. When arranged in the proper sequences with appropriate intention (kavvanah), these spoken words generate the same spiritual effects as physical Temple rituals. The human mouth becomes a spiritual altar, breath becomes fire, and words become offerings.

This substitutive framework is particularly evident in Aaron Berechia's approach to the Ketoret (incense offering), which he presents as possessing exceptional spiritual power even in its verbal form. The recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret formula—the Talmudic description of the Temple incense preparation—with proper intention creates, in his view, the same protective and unifying effects as the original Temple offering. This theological position leads him to argue forcefully for maintaining this recitation even in contexts like houses of mourning where certain other prayers

might be modified or omitted.

The larger implications of this substitutive theology extend beyond ritual to a profound reconceptualization of religious life after the Temple's destruction. If prayer truly replicates Temple service, then every synagogue becomes a miniature Temple, every prayer leader a kind of priest, and every worshiper a participant in cosmic Temple service. Through this theological move, Aaron Berechia transforms what might be seen as spiritual diminishment (the loss of the Temple) into spiritual opportunity, where divine service becomes more accessible and democratized, available to all who pray with proper knowledge and intention rather than limited to priests in Jerusalem.

Biblical and rabbinic foundations of the Ketoret

The biblical basis for the Ketoret (incense offering) appears first in Exodus 30:1–10, where God commands Moses to construct an altar specifically for burning incense, positioned directly before the Holy of Holies. The text specifies that Aaron, as High Priest, should burn fragrant incense on this altar every morning and evening, establishing it as a perpetual offering before the Lord throughout the generations. The sacred nature of this offering is underscored by the prohibition against unauthorized incense or any other offerings on this altar, with severe consequences promised for those who would create a similar formula for personal use.

The composition of the incense is detailed in Exodus 30:34–38, which lists four primary ingredients: stacte (nataf), onycha (shechelet), galbanum (chelbenah), and pure frankincense (levonah zakah), to be blended in equal parts, salted, and purified. This biblical formula would later be expanded in rabbinic tradition to include additional spices. The text emphasizes that this mixture is "most holy to the Lord," establishing its special status among Temple offerings.

The potent spiritual power of the Ketoret is dramatically illustrated in Numbers 17:6–15, where Aaron uses the incense as a means to halt a divine plague that had broken out among the Israelites. Standing between the dead and the living with a fire pan of incense, Aaron makes atonement for the people, and the plague is checked. This biblical episode becomes a foundational text for the Ketoret's apotropaic (protective) powers, frequently cited in *Ma'avar Yabok* to justify the recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret formula as spiritual protection against plagues and negative forces.

The rabbinic tradition significantly expanded upon these biblical foundations, most notably in the Talmudic passage that would eventually form the basis of the Pitum HaKetoret prayer. In Keritot 6a, the rabbis elaborate on the composition of the Temple incense, increasing the number of ingredients from the biblical four to eleven specific spices:

1. Balm (tzori)
2. Onycha (tziporen)
3. Galbanum (chelbenah)
4. Frankincense (levonah)

5. Myrrh (mor)
6. Cassia (ketziah)
7. Spikenard (shibolet nerd)
8. Saffron (karkom)
9. Costus (kosht)
10. Aromatic bark (kilufah)
11. Cinnamon (kinamon)

This list is supplemented with additional materials and procedures: Carshina lye for processing, Cyprus wine for soaking, salt of Sodom for preservation, and a herb called ma'aleh ashan ("smoke raiser") that caused the incense smoke to rise straight upward. The Talmud also specifies the precise quantities: 70 maneh each of the first four ingredients, 16 maneh each of the next four, 12 maneh of costus, 3 maneh of aromatic bark, and 9 maneh of cinnamon, totaling 368 maneh—one for each day of the solar year, with the extra three maneh used by the High Priest on Yom Kippur.

The rabbinic tradition further elaborated detailed rules governing the preparation and offering of the Ketoret. The Talmud specifies that the incense had to be finely ground, with the grinding accompanied by the repetition of the phrase "hadek heitev, heitev hadek" ("grind it thoroughly, thoroughly grind it") to ensure proper consistency. The mixing of the ingredients was considered a specialized craft, with the formula supposedly guarded by the Avtinas family, who were criticized for not sharing their techniques but ultimately vindicated when their secrecy was deemed necessary to prevent improper use of the sacred formula.

Following the Temple's destruction, the physical offering of incense became impossible, but its memory was preserved through the recitation of the biblical passages and Talmudic formulas describing the Ketoret. This recitation gradually became standardized in the Jewish liturgy, appearing in both the morning and afternoon prayer services. The kabbalistic tradition, drawing on these biblical and rabbinic foundations, would further develop the spiritual significance of the Ketoret, attributing to it profound cosmic effects when recited with proper intention—a development that reaches its fullest expression in works like *Ma'avar Yabok*.

Composition and symbolism of Temple incense

The eleven ingredients of the Temple incense enumerated in Talmudic tradition each carried symbolic significance within Jewish mystical thought, particularly as developed in kabbalistic sources and elaborated in *Ma'avar Yabok*. Aaron Berechia of Modena draws extensively on Zoharic interpretations that view the Ketoret components as corresponding to cosmic forces, divine attributes, and aspects of human spirituality.

The inclusion of galbanum (chelbenah) among the ingredients holds particular significance, as the Talmud notes that this substance has an unpleasant odor when burned alone. Its incorporation into the sacred incense formula prompted rabbinic

commentary that the community's prayers must include sinners among the righteous, just as the sacred incense included a malodorous element among its fragrant components. Aaron Berechia expands on this theme, explaining that the galbanum represents the forces of judgment (din) that must be "sweetened" through inclusion with the forces of mercy (rachamim) represented by the more pleasant spices. This reflects a central kabbalistic concept of "sweetening judgments" (mituk ha-dinim) that appears frequently throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*.

The number eleven also carries mystical significance, as Aaron Berechia explains that these ingredients correspond to the ten sefirot (divine emanations) plus the Ein Sof (Infinite One) that transcends them. Alternatively, some kabbalistic interpretations connect the eleven spices to the eleven ingredients missing from the holy incense in the absence of the Temple (the biblical "sammim" or "spices" mentioned twice in Exodus 30:34, counting as two), symbolizing the rectification of cosmic gaps created by the Temple's destruction.

The "smoke raiser" (ma'aleh ashan) ingredient receives special attention in kabbalistic commentaries. Aaron Berechia, following earlier mystical sources, interprets this component as representing the spiritual force that elevates prayer from the lower worlds to the higher divine realms. Just as this herb caused the physical incense smoke to rise straight upward rather than spreading outward, the proper intention during prayer causes the spiritual effects of prayer to ascend directly to their divine target rather than dissipating.

The precise measurements of the incense ingredients—368 maneh corresponding to the days of the solar year plus the three extra portions for Yom Kippur—are interpreted as establishing a cosmic connection between the Temple service and the cycles of time. Aaron Berechia explains that the daily Ketoret offering maintained cosmic harmony throughout the year, while the Yom Kippur offering by the High Priest in the Holy of Holies created a special channel for atonement and spiritual purification on the holiest day.

The grinding process, with its repetition of "hadek heitev, heitev hadek," is interpreted as symbolizing the necessity of thoroughly breaking down ego and material attachment (represented by the coarse spices) before one's prayers can ascend properly to the divine realms. Aaron Berechia connects this to the kabbalistic concept that prayer requires "breaking of the vessels" of ordinary consciousness to release the divine sparks contained within.

The prohibition against honey in the incense formula (specified in Leviticus 2:11) receives extensive mystical commentary. Aaron Berechia explains that honey, though sweet, burns quickly and represents ephemeral pleasures and superficial spirituality that lacks lasting substance. Its exclusion from the Ketoret symbolizes that genuine spiritual elevation requires sustained commitment rather than momentary enthusiasm.

The salt added to the incense mixture, particularly specified as "salt of Sodom," represents the element that preserves the covenant between God and Israel. Salt's preservative quality symbolizes the eternal nature of this relationship, while its connection to Sodom represents the transformation of judgment (associated with the destroyed city) into a force for preservation and sanctification.

These symbolic interpretations of the Ketoret's composition serve multiple functions in *Ma'avar Yabok*. They transform what might otherwise be seen as technical ritual details into profound spiritual teachings about prayer, divine service, and

cosmic harmony. They establish continuity between ancient Temple practice and contemporary prayer, suggesting that understanding these symbols allows modern worshipers to recreate the spiritual effects of the Temple service through proper prayer. And they provide a framework for understanding how the recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret formula can generate the protective and unifying effects attributed to the original incense offering.

Pitum HaKetoret and its recitation

The Pitum HaKetoret prayer, based primarily on the Talmudic passage in Keritot 6a, evolved from a descriptive text about Temple practice into a central liturgical element in Jewish prayer. This transformation reflects both the need to preserve Temple knowledge for the future restoration of service and the belief that recitation of these texts creates spiritual effects similar to the original offerings. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, Aaron Berechia provides detailed guidance for the proper recitation of this formula, drawing on traditions from Mantua and other Italian Jewish communities while incorporating kabbalistic interpretations of its efficacy.

The standardized text of the Pitum HaKetoret begins with the Talmudic enumeration of ingredients and their quantities, followed by descriptions of the preparation process, seasonal adjustments to the formula, and rules governing its offering in the Temple. It concludes with a biblical verse (Exodus 30:7–8) about Aaron's obligation to burn incense daily. This basic formula appears in both Sephardic and Ashkenazic prayer books, though with some variations in the surrounding liturgical framework.

Aaron Berechia places special emphasis on reciting this formula with proper intention (kavvanah) and clear articulation. He writes that each word should be pronounced distinctly, with awareness of its cosmic significance. This prescription reflects the kabbalistic understanding that Hebrew letters and words are not merely symbolic but are actual vessels for divine energy, capable of effecting real change in spiritual realms when properly activated through speech.

The tradition of reciting the Pitum HaKetoret twice daily—during morning (Shacharit) and afternoon (Minchah) prayers—parallels the twice-daily offering of physical incense in the Temple. Aaron Berechia endorses this practice, noting that it creates a frame around the day, providing spiritual protection during both active (daytime) and receptive (evening) spiritual states. He further recommends that those facing particular dangers or undertaking important journeys add additional recitations of the formula as spiritual protection.

A notable feature of the Pitum HaKetoret's recitation tradition is the practice of standing during its recitation, symbolizing the service of the priests who stood while offering incense in the Temple. This physical posture is understood as part of the enactment that transforms verbal recitation into spiritual service. Some traditions, particularly among Sephardic communities, also include specific hand gestures or body movements during recitation, representing the priest's actions in the Temple.

Ma'avar Yabok presents detailed instructions from the prayer customs of Mantua, which Aaron Berechia observed during his visit and found exemplary. These include reciting particular psalms before proceeding to the Ketoret formula, biblical verses about Abraham's hospitality and Jacob's instructions to his sons, lamenta-

tions over the Temple's destruction, and passages describing God's original instructions for the sacred incense preparation. Aaron Berechia notes that certain verses should be repeated three times (versus once with proper cantillation), reflecting kabbalistic principles about establishing spiritual patterns through repetition.

The recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret is traditionally preceded by a declaration of intent: "My God, may it be Your will that my recitation of the Ketoret passage be considered as if I had actually offered the incense before You." This declaration explicitly frames the recitation as a substitutive act, transforming what might otherwise be merely educational or commemorative into an actual spiritual service. Aaron Berechia adds that this declaration should be made with full awareness of the kabbalistic teaching that properly articulated words create the same spiritual effects as physical actions in higher realms.

A distinctive feature of the Pitum HaKetoret's recitation tradition is its maintenance even in contexts where other prayers might be abbreviated or modified. Aaron Berechia argues forcefully for preserving the complete recitation of this formula in houses of mourning, despite traditions that omit certain prayers in such settings. This position, which will be explored in more detail in a later section, reflects his view of the Ketoret's unique spiritual efficacy in protecting against negative forces that might be particularly present in the context of death.

The Pitum HaKetoret's position in the prayer service is also significant. In most liturgical traditions, it appears during the preliminary sections of prayer rather than within the core Amidah prayer, reflecting its status as preparation for more direct divine communion. However, Aaron Berechia notes that its spiritual effects extend throughout the prayer service, creating a protective framework within which other prayers can safely ascend. This positioning parallels the function of the physical incense in the Temple, which created a pleasing environment that facilitated divine-human communion.

Spiritual benefits of the Ketoret in Ma'avar Yabok

Among the most striking features of Aaron Berechia's treatment of the Ketoret is his systematic enumeration of ten specific spiritual benefits attributed to its recitation. This catalog appears in the fourth discourse of *Ma'avar Yabok*, where he draws extensively from Zoharic and other kabbalistic sources to establish the Ketoret as possessing exceptional efficacy among prayer formulae. These ten benefits transform the recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret from a mere commemorative act into a powerful spiritual technology with wide-ranging protective and elevating effects.

The first and perhaps most emphasized benefit is protection from plague. Drawing on the biblical account in Numbers 17, where Aaron's offering of incense halted a divine plague, Aaron Berechia affirms that proper recitation of the Ketoret formula creates a spiritual barrier against epidemic disease. This protective power extends beyond physical illness to spiritual "plagues" that might affect the soul, including negative thoughts, sinful inclinations, and harmful spiritual influences. In an era when plague was a recurring and devastating reality, this protective function would have held particular resonance.

The second benefit is protection from exile. Aaron Berechia explains that exile (galut) operates at multiple levels—physical displacement from the Land of Israel,

spiritual distance from God, and psychological alienation from one's true self. The Ketoret's fragrance symbolically reunites these separated elements, drawing the divine presence (Shekhinah) back from exile and helping to restore cosmic harmony. For Italian Jews living in diaspora, this spiritual counterforce to exile would have offered significant comfort.

The third benefit is blessing in one's work and material enterprises. The rising smoke of the incense symbolizes the elevation of physical activities to spiritual significance. Aaron Berechia explains that proper recitation of the Ketoret with awareness of this symbolism causes divine blessing to flow into one's material endeavors, transforming them from merely worldly pursuits into vehicles for divine service. This benefit addresses the practical concerns of his community while spiritualizing their economic activities.

The fourth benefit is protection from Gehenna (the realm of posthumous purification). The smoke and fire of the Ketoret are understood as a form of self-purification that preemptively accomplishes what Gehenna would otherwise need to achieve after death. Aaron Berechia explains that regular recitation of the Ketoret with proper intention gradually purifies the soul during life, reducing or eliminating the need for painful purification after death. This benefit connects the daily prayer practice to ultimate eschatological concerns.

The fifth benefit is nullification of negative spiritual forces, referred to variously as "chitzonim" (external forces), "sitra achra" (the other side), or "kelipot" (shells). These forces, understood in kabbalistic thought as entities that obstruct divine light and energy, are repelled by the "pleasant fragrance" of the Ketoret. Aaron Berechia specifies that the galbanum ingredient, though malodorous on its own, plays a crucial role in this function when properly integrated with the other spices—symbolizing the transformation of negative elements into positive spiritual forces.

The sixth benefit is nullification of witchcraft and harmful magical practices. While mainstream Judaism generally rejects magical practices, kabbalistic tradition acknowledges the reality of such forces while condemning their use. Aaron Berechia explains that the Ketoret, as a divinely sanctioned ritual with precise specifications, creates a spiritual field that neutralizes unauthorized attempts to manipulate cosmic forces. This benefit would have addressed contemporary anxieties about witchcraft and malevolent spiritual practices.

The seventh benefit is elimination of evil thoughts and purification of the mind. The grinding of the incense spices symbolizes the breaking down of mental constructs and attachments that obstruct clear spiritual perception. Aaron Berechia teaches that reciting the Ketoret mindfully helps to quiet mental chatter, dispel intrusive negative thoughts, and create mental space for divine inspiration. This benefit connects the ritual practice to psychological well-being and intellectual clarity.

The eighth benefit is securing a portion in both this world and the World to Come. The Ketoret's dual nature—physical substances producing spiritual effects—makes it a bridge between mundane and transcendent realms. Aaron Berechia explains that regular recitation of the formula with awareness of this symbolism helps to harmonize one's current life with one's eternal destiny, ensuring that present activities align with ultimate spiritual goals. This benefit addresses both immediate and eschatological concerns.

The ninth benefit is removal of harsh judgments (dinim) that might be de-

creed against an individual or community. In kabbalistic thought, divine judgment operates through specific channels that can be "sweetened" or mitigated through appropriate spiritual practices. Aaron Berechia describes the Ketoret as particularly effective in this "sweetening" process, transforming potential punishment into blessing through the unification of divine attributes that its recitation accomplishes. This benefit speaks to the fundamental human concern with navigating divine justice.

The tenth and culminating benefit is unification of divine forces (yichud). In kabbalistic thought, cosmic harmony depends on the proper relationship between different divine attributes or sefirot, particularly the "masculine" and "feminine" aspects of divinity. Aaron Berechia explains that the Ketoret's ascent represents the elevation of "feminine waters" (human prayer) that stimulates the descent of "masculine waters" (divine response), creating a cosmic unification that maintains the flow of blessing into all worlds. This highest benefit encompasses and enables all the others.

This systematic enumeration of benefits serves several functions in *Ma'avar Yabok*. It provides practical motivation for careful recitation of the Ketoret formula, connecting abstract kabbalistic concepts to tangible benefits that would resonate with readers. It establishes the Ketoret as a comprehensive spiritual practice addressing multiple dimensions of human concern, from physical health to cosmic harmony. And it serves as the foundation for Aaron Berechia's argument that the Pitum HaKetoret should be maintained even in contexts where other prayers might be modified or omitted, given its unique and wide-ranging spiritual efficacy.

Protective power of the Ketoret

The protective power of the Ketoret against plagues and negative spiritual forces emerges as perhaps its most emphasized benefit in *Ma'avar Yabok*. Aaron Berechia develops this theme extensively, drawing on biblical, rabbinic, and kabbalistic sources to establish the Ketoret as a uniquely potent spiritual shield. This emphasis likely reflects contemporary concerns with both physical epidemics and perceived spiritual dangers in 17th-century Italy.

The biblical foundation for the Ketoret's protective power appears in Numbers 17:6–15, where Aaron runs with a fire pan of incense into the midst of the congregation to halt a divine plague that had already claimed thousands of lives. Standing "between the dead and the living," Aaron offers the incense, and the plague is checked. Aaron Berechia quotes this passage repeatedly, noting that it provides explicit scriptural evidence for the incense's apotropaic (protective) powers. He emphasizes that if the physical incense could halt a divinely-sent plague, then its spiritual counterpart—the properly recited Pitum HaKetoret—should likewise provide protection against both physical and spiritual plagues.

The Talmudic tradition expands on this protective function, with passages in Shabbat 89a describing how the Angel of Death revealed the secret of the incense's protective power to Moses during his ascent to heaven. Aaron Berechia cites this as evidence that the Ketoret's efficacy against death and disease was recognized even in celestial realms. He further draws on midrashic sources that describe the cloud of incense as forming a protective barrier against harmful forces, preventing them from approaching the sanctuary where divine presence dwelled.

The Zohar, a primary source for Aaron Berechia's kabbalistic interpretations, elaborates extensively on the Ketoret's protective powers. He cites passages from Zohar Vayakhel (219a) describing the incense as creating spiritual pathways through which divine blessing can flow while blocking channels through which negative forces might enter. The Zohar connects this function to the inclusion of galbanum among the ingredients, explaining that this bitter substance specifically targets and neutralizes the "sitra achra" (the "other side" or forces of impurity). Aaron Berechia explores this concept in depth, explaining that the Ketoret's formula combines elements representing both mercy and judgment, creating a comprehensive spiritual shield that addresses multiple categories of negative influence.

The mechanism by which the Ketoret provides protection is explained through kabbalistic principles about the relationship between fragrance and spiritual essence. Aaron Berechia describes fragrance as the most spiritual of physical sensations, directly affecting the soul rather than merely the body. The pleasant fragrance of the Ketoret (with the exception of galbanum, which serves a specific function in targeting negative forces) is understood as attracting positive spiritual influences while repelling negative ones. This understanding is connected to the Zoharic concept that different types of spiritual entities are attracted or repelled by different fragrances, with divine and angelic forces drawn to the sacred incense while harmful entities flee from it.

A particularly significant aspect of the Ketoret's protective power in *Ma'avar Yabok* is its efficacy against the Angel of Death and forces associated with mortality. Aaron Berechia connects this to the context of the biblical incident, where Aaron stood "between the dead and the living" with the incense, suggesting that the Ketoret creates a boundary between life-affirming and death-dealing forces. This understanding takes on special significance in the context of end-of-life rituals, where Aaron Berechia argues for maintaining the recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret even in houses of mourning, precisely because its protective powers are especially needed in contexts where death has created spiritual vulnerabilities.

The protective power of the Ketoret extends beyond defense against harm to active promotion of healing and restoration. Aaron Berechia describes the incense as having the capacity to repair spiritual damage, heal cosmic breaches, and restore proper flow between divine and human realms. This restorative function operates at multiple levels: healing physical illness, repairing psychological damage from negative thoughts or experiences, and addressing cosmic imbalances that might affect an entire community or the world as a whole. The comprehensive nature of this protection and healing makes the Ketoret uniquely valuable among prayer formulas.

A distinctive feature of Aaron Berechia's treatment of the Ketoret's protective power is his insistence that it functions even—perhaps especially—in contexts normally associated with spiritual impurity or danger. He explicitly argues that the Pitum HaKetoret should be recited in houses of mourning, despite traditions that omit certain prayers in such settings, precisely because its protective powers are needed to neutralize potential negative forces associated with death. This position, which will be explored in the next section, reflects his understanding of the Ketoret as not merely defensive but actively transformative, capable of converting negative spiritual conditions into positive ones.

The practical implications of this understanding are significant. Aaron Berechia

recommends recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret during times of plague or epidemic, following the biblical precedent. He suggests that communities experiencing spiritual difficulties, such as conflicts or religious decline, should emphasize this prayer as a means of spiritual purification and protection. And he advises individuals facing particular challenges or transitions to incorporate additional recitations of the formula into their personal prayer practice as spiritual reinforcement. These recommendations transform the Ketoret from a historical commemoration into a living spiritual technology for addressing contemporary concerns.

Reciting Pitum HaKetoret in houses of mourning

One of the most distinctive aspects of Aaron Berechia's treatment of the Ketoret is his strong advocacy for maintaining its recitation even in houses of mourning, where certain other prayers are traditionally modified or omitted. This position places him at odds with some contemporary practices and reveals much about his understanding of the Ketoret's unique spiritual function and his approach to halakhic (legal) reasoning in matters of prayer and ritual.

The controversy centers on the general principle that certain expressions of praise and joy are considered inappropriate in houses of mourning, where the emphasis should be on consolation and reflection on mortality. Various Jewish communities developed different specific applications of this principle, with some omitting psalms of praise like Ashrei, others modifying the Kaddish prayer, and still others omitting the Pitum HaKetoret. Aaron Berechia acknowledges these practices but argues forcefully against the omission of the Ketoret formula, presenting both halakhic and kabbalistic justifications for his position.

From a halakhic perspective, Aaron Berechia argues that the Pitum HaKetoret is not primarily a prayer of praise but a technical description of Temple practices, comparable to the study of Temple-related Talmudic passages that are not omitted during mourning. He notes that the formula contains no expressions of joy or celebration, consisting instead of procedural details about ingredients and preparation methods. This categorization would exempt it from restrictions on prayers of praise in houses of mourning. He further cites the principle that practices established for health or protection reasons take precedence over mourning customs, arguing that the Ketoret's protective function against negative spiritual forces qualifies it for this exemption.

From a kabbalistic perspective, Aaron Berechia presents an even stronger case. He argues that the Ketoret is uniquely suited to houses of mourning precisely because of its protective and transformative powers. Death, in kabbalistic understanding, creates a spiritual vulnerability where negative forces might gain influence. The Ketoret's specific efficacy against such forces makes it particularly necessary in this context. He cites Zoharic passages describing the incense as having power to "eliminate plague and weaken the forces of grave judgment" affecting the deceased, suggesting that its recitation directly benefits the departed soul during its transition.

Aaron Berechia further argues that the Ketoret serves a unique function in "sweetening" the harsh judgments (dinim) associated with death. In kabbalistic thought, death represents the ultimate expression of divine judgment or restriction (din), which needs to be balanced or mitigated by divine mercy (rachamim).

The Ketoret, with its combination of ingredients representing both judgment and mercy, is uniquely suited to accomplish this "sweetening" process, transforming the spiritually dangerous condition of death into an opportunity for purification and elevation. This transformative function, he suggests, makes the Ketoret especially appropriate rather than inappropriate in houses of mourning.

The controversy reveals significant regional variations in Jewish practice that Aaron Berechia observed during his travels. He notes that in some communities, particularly in Ashkenazic (Central and Eastern European) regions, the custom was to omit the Pitum HaKetoret in houses of mourning, while in others, particularly Sephardic (Mediterranean and Middle Eastern) communities, it was maintained. He specifically praises the practice of Mantua, where the Ketoret was recited even during mourning, as representing the more authentic tradition based on kabbalistic understanding.

This disagreement reflects broader tensions between different approaches to Jewish law and custom. Aaron Berechia represents a perspective that gives substantial weight to kabbalistic considerations in determining proper practice, sometimes overriding or reinterpreting earlier customs based on mystical understandings of their cosmic significance. This approach stands in contrast to more strictly legalistic perspectives that might adhere to established customs regardless of their kabbalistic interpretation. The controversy over the Ketoret in houses of mourning thus becomes a microcosm of larger methodological debates within Jewish legal thought.

The practical implications of Aaron Berechia's position extend beyond this specific controversy. His defense of the Ketoret's recitation in houses of mourning establishes a principle that protective spiritual practices should generally be maintained even in contexts where other ritual modifications might be appropriate. This principle could be applied to other protective prayers or practices, creating a category of ritual elements that transcend contextual restrictions due to their special spiritual function. His position also implicitly challenges simplistic categories of prayers as either "joyful" or "solemn," suggesting that kabbalistic understanding reveals deeper dimensions that might not be immediately apparent from a prayer's surface content or emotional tone.

Aaron Berechia's treatment of this controversy also reveals his pastoral sensitivity alongside his mystical orientation. He recognizes that mourners are spiritually vulnerable, potentially subject to negative thoughts, emotional distress, and even harmful spiritual influences. His insistence on maintaining the Ketoret's recitation reflects concern for the mourners' spiritual welfare, providing them with a powerful protective practice during a challenging time. This pastoral dimension complements the theological and legal arguments, grounding mystical concepts in practical human needs.

Prayer as spiritual incense

At the heart of Aaron Berechia's treatment of the Ketoret lies a sophisticated kabbalistic understanding of how prayer words function as spiritual incense, creating the same metaphysical effects as the physical Temple offering. This understanding transforms what might otherwise be seen as merely commemorative recitation into a genuinely efficacious spiritual practice with concrete cosmic implications. In

Ma'avar Yabok, he elaborates this concept through multiple interconnected explanations of the spiritual mechanics of prayer.

The fundamental principle underlying this understanding is that Hebrew letters and words are not merely symbolic but are actual vessels of divine creative energy. Aaron Berechia draws on kabbalistic teachings that the twenty-two letters of the Hebrew alphabet were the instruments through which God created the world, as suggested in Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation), an early mystical text. When these letters are properly arranged in prayer, with appropriate intention (kavvanah), they activate the same creative forces that shaped existence, allowing human speech to affect cosmic reality. The words of the Pitum HaKetoret, recited with proper intention, thus become vessels for the same divine energies that operated through the physical incense in the Temple.

The efficacy of prayer words as spiritual incense depends on proper articulation and intention. Aaron Berechia emphasizes the importance of clear pronunciation, comparing the careful enunciation of prayer to the precise grinding and mixing of incense ingredients. Just as the physical incense required thorough blending to achieve its proper effect, the verbal formula requires proper integration of its components through deliberate and conscious recitation. He specifically instructs that the words of the Pitum HaKetoret should be "thoroughly ground" in one's mouth, creating a verbal parallel to the physical preparation process.

A central kabbalistic concept in this understanding is that words properly spoken create actual spiritual entities. Aaron Berechia explains that each letter uttered with proper intention generates a corresponding spiritual force or "angel" that ascends to accomplish its purpose in higher realms. The recitation of the complete Ketoret formula thus creates a complex spiritual structure analogous to the smoke cloud of the physical incense. This structure serves multiple functions: creating a channel for prayers to ascend, forming a barrier against negative forces, and establishing connections between different spiritual realms. The 11 ingredients of the Ketoret are understood as corresponding to 11 distinct spiritual forces that work together in this process.

The breath that carries prayer words receives particular attention in this kabbalistic understanding. Aaron Berechia describes breath as containing the "ruach" (spirit) of the person, making it a vehicle for soul energy. When this breath forms sacred words, it becomes a spiritual offering ascending to divine realms. He connects this concept to the biblical phrase "a pleasing aroma to the Lord," suggesting that properly formed prayer words create a spiritual fragrance that attracts divine presence and favor. This understanding transforms the metaphorical "sweetness" of prayer into a metaphysical reality, with properly articulated words actually generating spiritual "fragrances" perceptible in higher realms.

The kabbalistic understanding of prayer as incense includes detailed correspondences between physical elements of the Temple service and spiritual elements of prayer. Aaron Berechia describes the mouth as corresponding to the incense altar, the throat to the sanctuary, the lungs to the bellows that fanned the incense flames, and the heart to the fire pan that held the burning coals. This system of correspondences transforms the human body into a mobile Temple, capable of performing spiritual service anywhere. Each element of prayer is understood as activating its corresponding element in the celestial Temple, creating a parallel service in higher realms.

The concept of "ascending worlds" plays a crucial role in this understanding. Aaron Berechia explains that properly articulated prayers move through successive spiritual realms: from Asiyah (the world of physical action) through Yetzirah (formation) and Beriah (creation) to Atzilut (emanation), the highest realm accessible to human spiritual activity. This ascent parallels the rising smoke of the physical incense, which rose directly upward through the Temple to the highest point of the sanctuary. Different components of prayer affect different realms, with the Ketoret described as having particular efficacy in the realm of Yetzirah, where it can neutralize negative forces before they manifest in the physical world.

The timing of prayer receives significant attention in this kabbalistic framework. Aaron Berechia explains that different hours of the day are governed by different divine attributes, making certain prayers more effective at specific times. The morning and afternoon recitations of the Pitum HaKetoret correspond to the times when these attributes are most receptive to this particular form of spiritual service. He also notes that certain days (particularly Mondays and Thursdays, traditional days of judgment) and certain seasons (such as the Ten Days of Repentance between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur) make the Ketoret's recitation particularly important due to the spiritual conditions prevailing during these periods.

This elaborate kabbalistic understanding of prayer as spiritual incense serves multiple functions in *Ma'avar Yabok*. It provides theoretical justification for maintaining Temple-related prayers despite the Temple's destruction, establishing their ongoing efficacy rather than merely commemorative value. It offers practical guidance for more effective prayer, emphasizing the importance of proper intention, articulation, and awareness of cosmic correspondences. And it elevates everyday prayer practice from routine religious obligation to participation in cosmic processes, motivating greater devotion and attention to prayer details that might otherwise seem technical or archaic.

Cosmic unification through the Ketoret

The ultimate spiritual function of the Ketoret in Aaron Berechia's kabbalistic system is to create cosmic unifications (yichudim) and "sweeten" divine judgments (mituk ha-dinim). These interrelated processes represent the highest purposes of Jewish mystical practice, transforming the Ketoret from a merely protective ritual into a practice with profound cosmic significance. In *Ma'avar Yabok*, these concepts receive extensive treatment, revealing the author's sophisticated integration of Lurianic and Cordoverian kabbalistic systems.

The concept of unification (yichud) is fundamental to kabbalistic thought, particularly in its understanding of divine attributes. The ten sefirot or divine emanations are understood as differentiated expressions of divine energy that must remain in proper relationship for cosmic harmony to be maintained. The most fundamental of these relationships is between the "masculine" and "feminine" aspects of divinity, represented by the sefirot of Tiferet and Malkhut, or more generally by the divine names YHVH and Adonai. Human religious practices, properly performed, can facilitate the unification of these divine attributes, maintaining or restoring cosmic harmony. Aaron Berechia describes the Ketoret as uniquely effective in accomplishing these unifications, establishing it as a practice of cosmic significance.

The mechanism by which the Ketoret creates these unifications is explained through the kabbalistic concept of "feminine waters" (mayin nukvin) and "masculine waters" (mayin dukhrin). Human spiritual practice, including prayer, is understood as an ascent of "feminine waters" that stimulates the descent of "masculine waters" of divine blessing and energy. The ascending smoke of the incense, both in its physical Temple form and its spiritual prayer form, represents this ascent of feminine waters. Aaron Berechia explains that the Ketoret's specific formula, when properly recited, creates a particularly effective channel for this ascent, stimulating a corresponding descent of divine energy that unifies the cosmic realms.

The particular divine unification most associated with the Ketoret is between the sefirot of Binah (Understanding) and Malkhut (Kingdom). Aaron Berechia explains that Binah represents the source of divine judgment, while Malkhut represents its manifestation in the world. The Ketoret creates a channel between these sefirot that allows judgment to be modified or "sweetened" before reaching the world. This unification is symbolized by the combination of bitter and sweet ingredients in the incense formula, representing the integration of judgment and mercy in proper balance. The result of this unification is the transformation of potentially harmful judgment into constructive spiritual energy.

The concept of "sweetening judgments" (mituk ha-dinim) is closely related to these unifications. In kabbalistic thought, divine judgment (din) is not inherently negative but becomes problematic when disconnected from divine mercy (rachamim). The "sweetening" process reconnects these attributes, ensuring that judgment operates as a constructive rather than destructive force. Aaron Berechia describes the Ketoret as particularly effective in this sweetening process due to its composite nature, combining elements representing both judgment and mercy. The inclusion of galbanum, a bitter ingredient, among the sweet spices specifically serves this purpose, symbolizing the integration of judgment within a framework of mercy.

These unifications and sweetening processes operate at multiple levels. At the cosmic level, they maintain proper flow between divine realms, preventing blockages or imbalances that might manifest as suffering or disorder in the world. At the communal level, they create protection against collective hardships like plague, famine, or persecution. At the individual level, they transform personal challenges from purely negative experiences into opportunities for growth and purification. The comprehensive nature of these effects establishes the Ketoret as a practice with both universal and particular significance.

Aaron Berechia connects these cosmic functions of the Ketoret to specific elements of its composition and preparation. The eleven ingredients correspond to specific divine configurations in the highest realms. The precise measurements ensure proper balance between different spiritual forces. The "smoke raiser" ingredient that causes the incense cloud to rise straight upward represents the directed intention that guides the unification process. Even the prohibition against honey in the formula has cosmic significance, representing the exclusion of superficial sweetness that might mask rather than truly transform judgment.

The practical implications of these cosmic functions are significant. Aaron Berechia teaches that recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret with awareness of these unifications can help transform difficult personal circumstances, mitigate collective hardships, and contribute to cosmic harmony. He particularly recommends focusing on the sweetening aspect during times of apparent harsh judgment, such as

illness, community difficulties, or periods traditionally associated with increased divine judgment like the Ten Days of Repentance. This practical application transforms abstract kabbalistic concepts into spiritual resources for addressing real-life challenges.

These understandings of cosmic unification and sweetening judgments provide the theoretical foundation for Aaron Berechia's insistence on maintaining the Ketoret's recitation in all contexts, including houses of mourning. If the Ketoret uniquely facilitates these crucial cosmic processes, then its omission represents not merely the loss of one prayer among many but the absence of a key mechanism for cosmic harmony. This perspective elevates what might otherwise seem like a technical ritual detail into a matter of profound spiritual significance, justifying the emphasis it receives throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*.

Yom Kippur Katan and prayer in Modena

The relationship between the Ketoret and communal prayer practices receives particular attention in *Ma'avar Yabok*, with special focus on the ritual of Yom Kippur Katan (Minor Day of Atonement) and the specific prayer customs of Modena, Aaron Berechia's community. These discussions provide concrete examples of how the theoretical kabbalistic understandings of the Ketoret were implemented in actual religious practice, revealing the integration of mystical concepts into community life.

Yom Kippur Katan was a relatively recent innovation in Jewish practice during Aaron Berechia's time, having developed in 16th-century Safed among the kabbalistic circle of Rabbi Isaac Luria (the Arizal) before spreading to other Jewish communities, particularly in Italy. This practice involved observing a minor fast day on the day before each new month (Rosh Chodesh), except when the new month fell on Shabbat or coincided with another festival. The fast was accompanied by special prayers, confession (vidui), and sometimes additional practices like charitable giving or immersion in a ritual bath (mikveh).

Aaron Berechia describes the central role of the Ketoret in Yom Kippur Katan observances, particularly during the afternoon (Minchah) service. He explains that this timing is especially significant because the waning moon symbolizes the diminishment of divine light in the world, creating a period when judgments (dinim) are most likely to manifest. The Ketoret's power to sweeten these judgments makes it particularly valuable during this period. The recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret formula with special focus on its unifying and sweetening functions was understood as preparing the spiritual atmosphere for the coming month, ensuring that it would be characterized by mercy rather than harsh judgment.

The community of Modena, where Aaron Berechia served, apparently had particularly elaborate Yom Kippur Katan observances, which he describes in detail. These included special communal recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret with specific kavvanot (mystical intentions) focusing on the unification of divine names associated with the coming month. The prayer leader would recite certain portions aloud, with the congregation responding at designated points, creating a rhythmic pattern understood as generating specific spiritual effects. These observances would be followed by confessional prayers and sometimes by communal study of texts related

to the Temple and its service, further strengthening the connection to the original incense offering.

Aaron Berechia also describes a prayer society in Modena called "Me'irei Shachar" (Illuminators of Dawn), which gathered for early morning prayers with special emphasis on the purifying aspects of the Ketoret. This group, which he apparently led for about ten years, incorporated kabbalistic practices into their prayer, including specific breathing techniques, bodily movements, and kavvanot during the recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret. These practices were understood as creating a particularly effective channel for the ascent of prayer, benefiting both the individuals involved and the broader community through their spiritual effects.

The customs of Mantua regarding the Ketoret receive special praise in *Ma'avar Yabok*. Aaron Berechia reports being impressed by their practices during his visit, particularly noting their maintenance of the Pitum HaKetoret recitation in all contexts, including houses of mourning. He describes their specific ritual sequence: reciting particular psalms before proceeding to the Ketoret formula, incorporating biblical verses about Abraham's hospitality and Jacob's instructions to his sons, including lamentations over the Temple's destruction, and concluding with detailed passages describing God's original instructions for the sacred incense preparation. This elaborate framework placed the Ketoret within a narrative context that emphasized both its historical significance and its ongoing spiritual function.

A distinctive feature of communal Ketoret practices in these Italian communities was their integration of practical halakhic concerns with kabbalistic understandings. Aaron Berechia describes how practical questions about proper recitation—such as whether to stand or sit, which verses to repeat, and what gestures might accompany the words—were resolved through reference to both legal precedents and mystical significance. This integration reflects the broader synthesis of legalistic and mystical approaches characteristic of Italian Jewish communities in this period, where kabbalistic concepts informed rather than replaced halakhic observance.

The relationship between individual and communal recitation of the Ketoret receives significant attention. Aaron Berechia explains that while individual recitation has spiritual value, communal recitation creates more powerful effects due to the combined intentions of multiple worshippers. He describes how in both Modena and Mantua, the community would recite certain portions of the Pitum HaKetoret in unison, with special focus on the lists of ingredients and their measurements, creating a collective consciousness of the formula's spiritual significance. This communal emphasis reflects the understanding that cosmic unifications and sweetening of judgments are not merely individual spiritual achievements but collective responsibilities.

The seasonal cycle of Ketoret observances also features prominently in these communal practices. Aaron Berechia describes special emphasis on the recitation during transitional periods in the Jewish calendar, such as the days between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, the days before major festivals, and the period between Passover and Shavuot. These periods were understood as times when cosmic forces were in particular flux, making the stabilizing and harmonizing functions of the Ketoret especially important. Community leaders would sometimes add additional Ketoret recitations during these periods or incorporate special study sessions focusing on its significance.

These descriptions of actual communal practices provide important context

for understanding Aaron Berechia's theoretical discussions of the Ketoret. They demonstrate that the elaborate kabbalistic concepts presented in *Ma'avar Yabok* were not merely abstract speculations but informed concrete religious observances that shaped community life. They also reveal the extent to which kabbalistic understandings had penetrated mainstream Jewish practice in these Italian communities, with mystical concepts informing even routine liturgical decisions. This integration of theory and practice, mysticism and community life, is a distinctive feature of *Ma'avar Yabok* as a whole and particularly evident in its treatment of the Ketoret.

The Ketoret as microcosm

The treatment of the Ketoret in *Ma'avar Yabok* serves as a microcosm of the entire work's approach to Jewish spiritual practice, particularly in the context of end-of-life rituals and the soul's transition between worlds. Several key themes emerge from this exploration that illuminate Aaron Berechia's broader theological and practical framework.

First, the Ketoret exemplifies the work's fundamental premise that physical rituals from the Temple period can be effectively replaced by properly performed verbal counterparts. Just as the physical incense offering has been transformed into the recitation of the Pitum HaKetoret formula, so too have other Temple rituals been transformed into prayers, study, and contemplative practices that serve the same spiritual functions. This substitutive theology allows for the maintenance of cosmic harmony despite historical disruptions like the Temple's destruction or exile from the Land of Israel. It creates continuity between past and present religious experience while acknowledging the necessary adaptations to changed circumstances.

Second, the Ketoret demonstrates Aaron Berechia's integration of halakhic and kabbalistic approaches to religious practice. His discussions move fluidly between legal considerations about proper recitation practices and mystical explanations of the cosmic effects these practices generate. This integration reflects his view that law and mysticism are not separate domains but complementary dimensions of a unified religious system. The legal details ensure that practices are performed correctly, while mystical understandings reveal their deeper significance and motivate careful observance. This balanced approach characterizes *Ma'avar Yabok* as a whole, particularly in its treatment of death rituals where both practical and metaphysical concerns are equally important.

Third, the Ketoret reveals Aaron Berechia's concern with protection against negative spiritual forces, particularly in contexts involving illness, death, and transitions. The protective function attributed to the Ketoret parallels similar protective functions assigned to other prayers and practices throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*, such as Psalm 91 (Shir Shel Pega'im/Song of Afflictions), the recitation of divine names, and specific deathbed confessional formulas. This consistent emphasis on spiritual protection reflects an understanding of human vulnerability, particularly during major life transitions, and provides practical resources for navigating these vulnerable periods safely.

Fourth, the cosmic unifications attributed to the Ketoret reflect the work's broader concern with maintaining harmony between divine realms, particularly in contexts where this harmony might be disrupted. Death represents the ulti-

mate expression of divine judgment (din), which must be balanced by divine mercy (rachamim) to prevent cosmic imbalance. The Ketoret's role in "sweetening judgments" parallels similar functions attributed to other practices throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*, creating a comprehensive system for maintaining cosmic harmony during potentially disruptive transitions. This concern with balance extends from the highest cosmic levels to the most practical details of ritual observance.

Fifth, the communal dimensions of Ketoret practice reflect the work's broader understanding of individual and collective religious responsibility. While individuals bear responsibility for their own spiritual preparation, the community provides essential support through shared ritual practices, mutual assistance, and collective generation of spiritual merit. The prayer societies and communal observances described in connection with the Ketoret exemplify this collective dimension of spiritual practice that appears throughout *Ma'avar Yabok*, particularly in its descriptions of proper care for the dying and deceased.

Finally, the Ketoret's function as a bridge between worlds—connecting the physical and spiritual, the mundane and sacred, the human and divine—exemplifies the central metaphor of *Ma'avar Yabok* itself. The work's title, referring to Jacob's crossing of the Yabok River before his transformative encounter with the angel, establishes transition between realms as its organizing principle. The Ketoret, with its ascending smoke connecting earth to heaven, serves as a perfect symbol for this transitional function. Just as the Ketoret creates channels between cosmic realms, the practices detailed throughout *Ma'avar Yabok* create channels for the soul's transition from this world to the next.

Aaron Berechia's treatment of the Ketoret thus provides not merely technical information about one prayer formula but a window into his entire approach to Jewish spiritual practice. The integration of practical ritual details with profound mystical significance, the balance between individual and communal responsibilities, the concern with both protection from harm and elevation to higher spiritual states, and the fundamental understanding of religious practice as creating connections between worlds—all these elements characterize both his approach to the Ketoret specifically and *Ma'avar Yabok* as a whole. Understanding the Ketoret's place in this system illuminates not only one specific prayer practice but an entire worldview in which seemingly mundane ritual details participate in cosmic processes of profound spiritual significance.

Appendix J

Kavvanah (Intention) and Yichudim (Unifications)

In the sacred architecture of Jewish prayer and ritual, few concepts carry as much transformative potential as *kavvanah* (כוונה), often translated simply as "intention." Yet this rendering fails to capture the profound depth and cosmic significance attributed to this practice, especially within the mystical dimensions of Judaism. The concept of kavvanah stands at the intersection of human consciousness and divine reality, serving as both the fulcrum and the vehicle through which finite human actions acquire infinite spiritual consequence.

The Hebrew term *kavvanah* derives from the root *kivven* (כיוון), meaning "to direct" or "to aim." In its most basic sense, kavvanah refers to the focusing of one's attention and purpose during prayer and ritual observance. The Talmud already recognizes the fundamental importance of this mental orientation, with Rabbi Simeon declaring, "Prayer without kavvanah is like a body without a soul" (Jerusalem Talmud, Berakhot 4:1). This early conception primarily emphasized the avoidance of distraction and the conscious awareness of standing before God, what later authorities would term *kavvanat ha-lev* (intention of the heart).

As Jewish mystical traditions developed, particularly through the medieval Hasidei Ashkenaz movement and the emergence of Kabbalah, the concept of kavvanah underwent a profound transformation. No longer merely a matter of mental focus, kavvanah became increasingly understood as a technique for influencing cosmic reality itself. The mystics of Safed in the 16th century, particularly Rabbi Isaac Luria (the Arizal) and his disciples, elaborated a complex system of kavvanot that could activate specific channels between human consciousness and divine emanations, creating effects across multiple spiritual worlds.

In Ma'avar Yabok, Aaron Berechia of Modena presents a sophisticated understanding of kavvanah that synthesizes these various historical strands. Drawing heavily on Lurianic Kabbalah while maintaining accessibility for practitioners, he portrays kavvanah as the essential mechanism through which human religious action achieves metaphysical potency. Throughout the text, we encounter references to proper kavvanah as necessary for everything from daily prayer to the most sensitive

moment of the soul's transition at death. For Berechia, kavvanah is not merely an enhancement to ritual action but its very essence, the force that transmutes physical gesture and vocalized words into cosmic transformation.

The text repeatedly emphasizes that "prayer without kavvanah is like a body without a soul," echoing earlier rabbinic statements but investing them with new, kabbalistic significance. Berechia explains that without proper intention, ritual actions remain trapped in the physical world, unable to ascend to higher realms where they might effect spiritual repair (*tikkun*). Conversely, when performed with the appropriate kavvanah, even seemingly mundane religious actions can pierce through multiple cosmic levels, influencing divine emanations and drawing down celestial abundance.

Levels of Kavvanah

Jewish tradition recognizes multiple levels of kavvanah, forming a hierarchy of intentional states that correlate with different levels of spiritual development. At its most fundamental level, kavvanah requires simply understanding the meaning of the words one is reciting and maintaining awareness that one stands before God. This basic level, sometimes called *kavvanat ha-perush* (intention of the meaning), is considered essential for the fulfillment of religious obligations according to normative halakhah.

A more elevated form involves emotional engagement with the prayer content, what might be termed *kavvanat ha-lev* (intention of the heart). This entails not merely intellectual comprehension but also emotional resonance with the prayer's themes—experiencing awe during praise of God's greatness, genuine remorse during confessional prayers, or heartfelt gratitude during thanksgiving. Medieval pietistic movements like Hasidei Ashkenaz particularly emphasized this emotional dimension of kavvanah.

The kabbalistic tradition, however, introduced a significantly more complex level of kavvanah that transcends both intellectual understanding and emotional engagement. This mystical kavvanah, which we might call *kavvanat ha-sod* (intention of the mystery), involves consciousness of the cosmic correspondences and divine unifications activated through specific prayers and rituals. It requires knowledge of esoteric teachings about the structure of divine emanations (sefirot) and the mechanics of cosmic influence.

Ma'avar Yabok operates primarily at this third, mystical level of kavvanah, though it acknowledges the importance of the more basic levels as prerequisites. Throughout the text, Berechia provides detailed instructions for specific kavvanot to be employed during different prayers, rituals, and especially during deathbed practices. These kavvanot often involve visualization of divine names, contemplation of specific sefirot, and awareness of the cosmic effects being generated through particular verbal formulations.

For instance, the text instructs that when reciting the Shema prayer at the time of death, one should have kavvanah that unifies the divine masculine (represented by the Tetragrammaton) with the divine feminine (represented by the name Adonai). This unification is not merely a conceptual exercise but is understood to actually facilitate the soul's transition, creating a protective pathway through which it can

ascend to higher realms.

Similarly, when reciting psalms for the sick, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes specific kavvanot directed toward activating divine mercy and "sweetening" harsh judgments. The practitioner is instructed to visualize the divine name YHVH with specific vowel points that correspond to the attribute of mercy, thereby channeling healing energy to the afflicted person.

What distinguishes these mystical kavvanot from their more basic counterparts is their explicit cosmic intention. The practitioner is not merely focusing on personal devotion or emotional connection but is consciously participating in a metaphysical process that affects the structure of divine reality itself. This represents a profound democratization of spiritual power, suggesting that properly trained individuals—not just exceptional mystics—can influence cosmic forces through disciplined application of kavvanah.

The metaphysics of intention

To understand how Ma'avar Yabok conceptualizes the efficacy of kavvanah, we must first grasp its underlying metaphysical framework. Drawing on kabbalistic cosmology, Berechia presents a universe structured as a series of nested spiritual worlds, each representing a different level of divine manifestation. These worlds—Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action)—form a continuous chain linking the infinite divine source (Ein Sof) with the finite material world.

Within this cosmic architecture, human consciousness occupies a unique position. Though physically situated in the lowest world (Asiyah), the human soul contains elements derived from all higher worlds, making it capable of interacting with and influencing these supernal realms. Prayer and ritual, when performed with proper kavvanah, serve as vehicles through which human consciousness can ascend through these worlds, effecting changes that subsequently cascade back down into physical reality.

Berechia explains this process using the kabbalistic concept of "arousal from below" (*itaruta di-letata*). Human religious action, when directed by proper kavvanah, creates an "arousal" or activation in the lower worlds that stimulates a corresponding "arousal from above" (*itaruta di-le'eila*)—a flow of divine energy and blessing from higher realms. This reciprocal dynamic establishes prayer not merely as petition but as a causal mechanism within the cosmic order.

The text frequently employs hydraulic metaphors to describe this process, likening kavvanah to the opening of channels (*tzinnorot*) through which divine abundance can flow. These channels connect various divine attributes (sefirot) with each other and with the lower worlds. Blockages in these channels, caused by sin or improper religious practice, impede the flow of divine blessing. Proper kavvanah serves to clear these blockages and restore cosmic circulation.

One of the most significant effects of proper kavvanah, according to Ma'avar Yabok, is the "sweetening of judgments" (*mituk ha-dinim*). This technical kabbalistic term refers to the transformation of divine severity (associated with the attribute of Gevurah/Din) into mercy (associated with Hesed/Rahamim). Judgment in its unmitigated form can manifest as suffering, illness, or death in the physical

world. Through specific kavvanot, particularly those involving divine names associated with mercy, the practitioner can "sweeten" these judgments, tempering their severity and channeling them into constructive rather than destructive expressions.

Ma'avar Yabok provides concrete examples of this process in its instructions for prayers over the sick. The text prescribes specific kavvanot focused on the divine name YHVH with vowel points corresponding to mercy, explaining that this visualization actually draws healing energy from the attribute of Hesed to counterbalance the judgments manifesting as illness. Similarly, deathbed kavvanot are designed to "sweeten" the judgment of death itself, ensuring that the soul experiences a gentle rather than harsh transition.

Another crucial effect of kavvanah is the facilitation of divine unifications (*yichudim*), which we will explore in greater detail in the next section. These unifications harmonize different divine attributes, creating a balanced cosmic flow that benefits both upper and lower worlds. Proper kavvanah during prayer and ritual serves as the catalyst for these unifications, making the human practitioner an active participant in the maintenance of cosmic harmony.

Notably, Ma'avar Yabok suggests that the efficacy of kavvanah does not depend entirely on the practitioner's spiritual status. While greater purity and devotion certainly enhance its power, the text indicates that even ordinary individuals can effect significant spiritual changes through proper kavvanah. This democratization of mystical practice represents a significant development in kabbalistic thought, making advanced spiritual techniques accessible to a broader community beyond elite mystics.

Yichudim: unifying divine realms

The concept of *yichudim* (unifications) stands as one of the most profound and technically complex aspects of kabbalistic practice presented in Ma'avar Yabok. The term derives from the Hebrew root *yachad* (יחד), meaning "to unite," and refers to the mystical unification of divine attributes or emanations through properly directed human consciousness.

The theological foundation for yichudim lies in the kabbalistic understanding of divine fragmentation and restoration. According to Lurianic Kabbalah, the process of creation involved a contraction (*tzimtzum*) of divine light, followed by an emanation of that light into vessels that subsequently shattered (*shevirat ha-kelim*). This cosmic catastrophe resulted in a state of disharmony where divine attributes became separated from one another and sparks of divine light became entrapped in the material realm.

The ultimate purpose of religious life, in this view, is to participate in the restoration of cosmic harmony through the reunification of these separated divine elements. Yichudim represent the specific mystical techniques through which this reunification is accomplished, using human consciousness as the activating agent.

Ma'avar Yabok places particular emphasis on the unification of masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, typically represented by the Tetragrammaton (YHVH, associated with the masculine attribute of Tiferet) and the divine name Adonai (associated with the feminine attribute of Malkhut). This particular unification, frequently referred to as "unifying the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine

Presence" (*l'yachada kudsha brich hu u-shechintei*), serves as the paradigmatic model for all other yichudim.

The text provides detailed instructions for achieving this unification through specific kavvanot during prayer and ritual. For example, when reciting the Shema prayer, the practitioner is instructed to visualize the letters of YHVH and Adonai intertwining or overlapping, representing the union of these divine aspects. This visualization is to be accompanied by the conscious intention to restore divine harmony through human devotional activity.

Ma'avar Yabok also discusses more complex yichudim involving multiple divine names and attributes. For instance, the text describes yichudim that unite the divine names Ehyeh, YHVH, and Adonai, corresponding to the three primary soul components of neshamah, ruach, and nefesh. These more elaborate unifications often involve sophisticated letter permutations, vowel combinations, and visualization techniques that reflect the influence of Lurianic Kabbalah.

The practical application of yichudim extends beyond regular prayer to specific life transitions, particularly illness and death. Berechia provides detailed instructions for yichudim to be performed at the deathbed, designed to facilitate the soul's peaceful transition by creating harmonious pathways through the divine realms. These deathbed yichudim often involve visualization of the 42-letter divine name (Shem Mem-Bet) and its correspondence to various cosmic structures.

Importantly, Ma'avar Yabok presents yichudim not merely as theoretical constructs but as practical techniques with measurable effects. The text repeatedly emphasizes that proper execution of these unifications can heal the sick, comfort the dying, protect the deceased's soul, and bring blessing to the community. This practical orientation reflects the book's overall purpose as a manual for communal religious leaders responsible for caring for the ill and dying.

The concept of yichudim also carries significant theological implications regarding human agency in the cosmic order. By suggesting that human consciousness can directly influence divine configurations, Ma'avar Yabok attributes remarkable spiritual potency to human religious action. This perspective positions humans not merely as passive recipients of divine influence but as active partners in the ongoing work of cosmic restoration (*tikkun olam*).

Kavvanot for different times

A distinctive feature of the kavvanah system presented in Ma'avar Yabok is its temporal specificity. Different times—whether times of day, days of the week, or special occasions in the liturgical calendar—require different kavvanot. This temporal mapping reflects the kabbalistic understanding that cosmic influences fluctuate according to regular cycles, creating windows of opportunity for particular types of spiritual work.

The daily prayer cycle forms the basic framework for these temporal kavvanot. Morning prayers (*shacharit*) are associated with the divine attribute of Hesed (loving-kindness) and the patriarch Abraham. Practitioners are instructed to direct their kavvanah toward drawing down this attribute's benevolent influence. Afternoon prayers (*minchah*) correspond to Gevurah (strength/judgment) and the patriarch Isaac, requiring kavvanot focused on "sweetening" potential harshness.

Evening prayers (*arvit/ma'ariv*) align with Tiferet (beauty/harmony) and the patriarch Jacob, with kavvanot oriented toward balancing the day's spiritual energies.

Ma'avar Yabok explains that these correspondences are not arbitrary but reflect objective cosmic rhythms. The morning hours naturally channel the energy of divine mercy, making this time particularly favorable for prayers seeking healing or blessing. Conversely, afternoon hours intensify the attribute of judgment, requiring special kavvanot to mitigate potential severity. The text advises that confession (*vidui*) is most effective when performed in the morning hours when mercy predominates, though it acknowledges that deathbed confession must be performed whenever necessary, regardless of timing.

Days of the week similarly correspond to different sefirot and require specific kavvanot:

- Sunday corresponds to Hesed (loving-kindness)
- Monday corresponds to Gevurah (strength/judgment)
- Tuesday corresponds to Tiferet (beauty/harmony)
- Wednesday corresponds to Netzach (eternity/victory)
- Thursday corresponds to Hod (splendor/acknowledgment)
- Friday corresponds to Yesod (foundation/connection)
- Sabbath corresponds to Malkhut (kingdom/manifestation)

Berechia provides detailed instructions for adjusting one's kavvanot according to these daily correspondences. For example, prayers for the sick performed on Monday should include additional focus on divine names associated with mercy to counterbalance the day's natural orientation toward judgment. Conversely, prayers on Sunday can more directly access healing energies through kavvanot aligned with the day's merciful character.

Beyond daily and weekly cycles, Ma'avar Yabok also addresses special kavvanot for significant calendar occasions. The new moon (Rosh Chodesh) receives particular attention, with the text prescribing specific fasting and prayer practices with kavvanot designed to "renew" spiritual energy in conjunction with the lunar cycle. Similarly, the monthly observance of Yom Kippur Katan (Minor Day of Atonement) includes specialized kavvanot for spiritual purification.

Perhaps most significantly, Ma'avar Yabok details specific kavvanot for moments of transition between life and death. These kavvanot must be adjusted according to the dying person's condition, the time of day, and even the specific cause of death. For instance, different kavvanot are prescribed for peaceful natural death versus violent or sudden death, with the latter requiring more intensive focus on divine names associated with mercy and protection.

This temporal mapping of kavvanot reflects a sophisticated understanding of cosmic rhythms and their interaction with human spiritual practice. By aligning one's intentions with these rhythms, the practitioner can maximize the efficacy of prayer and ritual, ensuring that human religious action harmonizes with rather than contradicts the natural flow of divine influence through time.

Divine names and their vowelization

At the technical core of the kavvanah system presented in Ma'avar Yabok lies the contemplation of divine names (*shemot ha-kodesh*) and their various vowelizations. These names are not merely designations but are understood as actual channels of divine energy, each corresponding to different divine attributes and cosmic functions. Proper contemplation of these names, with appropriate vowel patterns, serves as the primary mechanism through which human consciousness influences spiritual realms.

The text places particular emphasis on three divine names that form the acronym YaBOK (יב״ק):

- Ehyeh (אהיה) – associated with the highest soul level (neshamah) and the world of Beriah
- YHVH (יקוק) – associated with the middle soul level (ruach) and the world of Yetzirah
- Adonai (אדני) – associated with the lowest soul level (nefesh) and the world of Asiyah

These three names have a combined numerical value (gematria) of 112, which equals the numerical value of YaBOK. This correspondence is not coincidental but reflects the book's central metaphor of "crossing the Yabok" as a spiritual transition facilitated by proper contemplation of these divine names.

Ma'avar Yabok provides detailed instructions for visualizing these names with specific vowel points that activate different spiritual qualities. For instance, the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) can be vowelized in multiple ways, each corresponding to a different sefirah:

- With *segol* vowels (יֶקֶוֶק) – corresponding to Keter (Crown)
- With *cholam* vowels (יְקוֹוָק) – corresponding to Hokhmah (Wisdom)
- With *kamatz* vowels (יָקוֹוָק) – corresponding to Binah (Understanding)
- With *patach* vowels (יָקוֹק) – corresponding to Hesed (Loving-kindness)

The text instructs practitioners to visualize these differently vowelized divine names during different prayers and rituals, depending on which divine attribute they wish to activate. During healing prayers, for instance, one should focus on YHVH with vowels corresponding to Hesed to draw down healing energy. During deathbed rituals, vowelizations associated with mercy are emphasized to ensure gentle judgment.

Beyond these primary divine names, Ma'avar Yabok also discusses the mystical significance of the 42-letter divine name (Shem Mem-Bet), which plays a central role in deathbed and burial rituals. This name is divided into seven groups of six letters each, with each group corresponding to a different day of creation and a different divine attribute. The text provides detailed instructions for meditating on this name during the seven circuits (hakafot) performed around the deceased's bier, creating a protective spiritual envelope for the departing soul.

The technical complexity of these name-based kavvanot reflects the influence of Lurianic Kabbalah, which developed elaborate systems for manipulating divine

names as a form of theurgy (ritual influence on divine realms). However, Ma'avar Yabok presents these techniques in a relatively accessible format, making them available to religious functionaries without extensive kabbalistic training.

It's important to note that these divine name contemplations were not meant to be merely mental exercises but were understood as actual manipulations of cosmic energy. The text repeatedly emphasizes that proper visualization of divine names with appropriate vowels creates tangible effects in both spiritual and physical realms. This belief in the causal efficacy of properly directed consciousness distinguishes kabbalistic kavvanah from more general concepts of devotional focus.

Sefirotic Correspondences in Prayer and Ritual

The divine emanations known as sefirot constitute the primary structural framework for kavvanah practice in Ma'avar Yabok. These ten emanations—Keter (Crown), Hokhmah (Wisdom), Binah (Understanding), Hesed (Loving-kindness), Gevurah (Strength), Tiferet (Beauty), Netzach (Victory), Hod (Splendor), Yesod (Foundation), and Malkhut (Kingdom)—represent different aspects of divine manifestation and serve as the cosmic channels through which divine energy flows into creation.

Berechia provides a comprehensive system for directing one's kavvanah toward specific sefirot during different prayers and rituals. This direction is not arbitrary but corresponds to the inherent connection between particular prayers and specific divine attributes. For instance, prayers of praise generally correspond to Hesed, prayers of petition to Gevurah, and prayers of thanksgiving to Tiferet. By consciously aligning one's intention with these correspondences, the practitioner can maximize the efficacy of prayer as a means of influencing cosmic flows.

The Amidah prayer (the central standing prayer of Jewish liturgy) receives particular attention in Ma'avar Yabok's sefirotic mapping. Each of its nineteen blessings corresponds to a specific sefirah or combination of sefirot. For example, the first blessing (Avot/Patriarchs) corresponds to Hesed through its association with Abraham, while the second blessing (Gevurot/Powers) naturally aligns with Gevurah. The practitioner is instructed to visualize each blessing as activating its corresponding sefirah, creating a systematic ascent through the divine emanations over the course of the prayer.

Deathbed rituals in Ma'avar Yabok involve particularly sophisticated sefirotic kavvanot. The text instructs those attending the dying person to direct their intention toward facilitating the soul's journey through the sefirotic system, from Malkhut (the lowest emanation) through progressively higher levels. Specific verses, divine names, and visualizations are prescribed for each sefirotic level, creating a spiritual ladder for the ascending soul.

The process of "sweetening judgments" (*mituk ha-dinim*) mentioned earlier operates primarily through sefirotic manipulation. When illness or death threatens, the attribute of Gevurah (judgment) is understood to be predominant. Through proper kavvanah, the practitioner attempts to activate Hesed (loving-kindness) and channel its energy to balance and temper Gevurah's severity. This balancing is visualized as a flow of divine light from the right side of the sefirotic structure (associated with Hesed) to the left side (associated with Gevurah).

Ma'avar Yabok also addresses the kabbalistic concept of "faces" (*partzu-*

fim)—complex configurations of sefirot that function as complete divine personae. Five primary partzufim are recognized in Lurianic Kabbalah: Arich Anpin (Long Face), Abba (Father), Imma (Mother), Zeir Anpin (Small Face), and Nukvah (Female). The text provides kavvanot for interacting with these partzufim during different rituals, particularly those involving the transition between life and death.

One of the most significant sefirotic kavvanot presented in Ma'avar Yabok involves the "thirteen rectifications of the holy beard" (*yud-gimel tikkunei dikna*). These thirteen channels of divine mercy, associated with the partzuf of Arich Anpin, are visualized during prayers for the sick and dying as conduits of compassionate energy capable of overriding harsh judgments. The practitioner is instructed to contemplate each of these channels in sequence, creating a comprehensive activation of divine mercy.

This sefirotic framework provides a cosmic map for directing kavvanah, allowing practitioners to target specific divine attributes and influences based on particular needs and circumstances. By understanding the correspondence between human actions and sefirotic dynamics, religious functionaries can transform seemingly simple prayers and rituals into sophisticated tools for cosmic influence.

Deathbed Kavvanot

Ma'avar Yabok devotes particular attention to kavvanot specifically designed for deathbed situations, reflecting the book's primary purpose as a manual for religious functionaries responsible for end-of-life care. These deathbed kavvanot are presented as essential tools for facilitating the soul's peaceful transition from physical to spiritual existence, protecting it from negative forces and guiding it toward divine reception.

The text emphasizes that the moment of death represents a critical spiritual juncture where proper kavvanah can dramatically influence the soul's posthumous experience. Unlike regular prayer kavvanot, which primarily affect the practitioner's own spiritual state, deathbed kavvanot are understood to directly impact another person's soul during its most vulnerable transition. This intercessory function places special responsibility on those performing these kavvanot.

Central to Ma'avar Yabok's deathbed system is the recitation of the Shema prayer with specific kavvanah. Those attending the dying person are instructed to recite "Hear, O Israel: the Lord our God, the Lord is One" while visualizing the unification of the divine names YHVH and Adonai. This unification creates what the text describes as a "pathway of light" through which the soul can ascend safely to higher realms.

Specific attention is given to the final word of the Shema—"echad" (one)—which should be extended while visualizing the soul's separation from the body and its ascent through the cosmic levels. The numerical value of "echad" (13) corresponds to the thirteen attributes of divine mercy, creating a protective envelope around the departing soul. The dying person, if conscious, is encouraged to focus their own kavvanah on surrendering their soul to God through this word, echoing Rabbi Akiva's martyrdom where he extended the word "echad" until his soul departed.

Another crucial deathbed kavvanah involves the recitation of 112 biblical verses organized according to the three divine names constituting the acronym YaBOK.

Twenty-one verses correspond to the name Ehyeh, twenty-six to the Tetragrammaton, and sixty-five to Adonai. These verses are to be recited with the kavvanah of creating a spiritual vehicle for the soul's ascent through corresponding cosmic levels.

For the final moments before death, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes the recitation of "Lekh…" ("Go forth") with the kavvanah of gently releasing the soul from its bodily attachment. This recitation is to be accompanied by visualization of the verse from Song of Songs 5:6, "My soul departed when he spoke," understood as a loving divine summons rather than a harsh expulsion.

The text also provides specific kavvanot for those situations where the dying person experiences difficulty releasing their soul. These involve visualization of the angels Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, and Uriel stationed at the four sides of the deathbed, with the Divine Presence (Shekhinah) above the person's head. This angelic configuration is understood to create a protective field that facilitates the soul's departure by neutralizing negative forces that might impede its release.

After death has occurred, Ma'avar Yabok prescribes kavvanot focused on the continued protection of the soul during its initial journey. These include visualization of Psalm 91 (known as "the Song of Afflictions") as a protective shield around the deceased, and contemplation of specific divine names during the seven circuits (hakafot) performed around the bier.

Throughout these deathbed instructions, the text emphasizes that proper kavvanah directly affects the deceased's posthumous experience. Those who depart with appropriate spiritual preparation and with the assistance of properly directed kavvanot by attendants are understood to experience a gentle judgment and swift ascent to paradise. Conversely, those who die without proper kavvanah may face a more difficult transition requiring posthumous purification.

This cosmic significance attributed to deathbed kavvanot reflects Ma'avar Yabok's overall perspective on human religious consciousness as a potent force capable of influencing not only one's own spiritual state but also the metaphysical conditions of others during critical transitions.

Letter meditation: the atomistic approach

A distinctive feature of the kavvanah system presented in Ma'avar Yabok is its atomistic approach to sacred language, treating individual Hebrew letters and their combinations as discrete units of spiritual power. This approach draws on the kabbalistic understanding of Hebrew as the divine language of creation, with each letter containing unique metaphysical properties and cosmic correspondences.

Berechia instructs practitioners to meditate on the individual letters of prayers and divine names, not merely as linguistic components but as actual channels of divine energy. Each letter of the Hebrew alphabet corresponds to specific sefirot, angels, body parts, and cosmic functions. By properly contemplating these correspondences during prayer, the practitioner can activate the letter's inherent spiritual potency.

For instance, the four letters of the Tetragrammaton (YHVH) correspond to four primary sefirot: Yod to Hokhmah, the first Heh to Binah, Vav to Tiferet, and the final Heh to Malkhut. When reciting this divine name (or visualizing it, as

direct pronunciation is prohibited), the practitioner should contemplate each letter sequentially, visualizing its connection to its corresponding sefirah and the flow of divine energy through that connection.

Ma'avar Yabok also discusses the significance of letter permutations and combinations, particularly in relation to the 231 "gates" (*sha'arim*) formed by pairing each Hebrew letter with every other letter. These combinations, first described in the ancient mystical text Sefer Yetzirah, are understood as the fundamental building blocks of creation. By meditating on specific combinations during prayer, the practitioner can influence the cosmic forces they represent.

The text provides detailed instructions for contemplating the 42-letter divine name, which consists of seven groups of six letters. Each group should be visualized with awareness of its specific cosmic function and angelic correspondence. Similarly, the 72-letter divine name, derived from three verses in Exodus 14:19–21, is to be contemplated letter by letter during certain critical prayers, particularly those relating to protection from negative forces.

Beyond divine names, Ma'avar Yabok applies this atomistic approach to biblical verses used in healing and deathbed rituals. The 112 verses associated with the YaBOK acronym are to be recited with awareness of how each letter contributes to the verse's overall spiritual effect. Certain key verses should be visualized letter by letter, creating a mental image of the Hebrew text that serves as a vehicle for divine energy.

This letter-focused kavvanah reflects the influence of Abraham Abulafia's ecstatic Kabbalah, which emphasized letter permutation as a technique for achieving mystical states. However, Ma'avar Yabok adapts this approach for practical religious purposes rather than pure mystical experience, showing how letter meditation can be integrated into conventional prayer and ritual.

The text's atomistic approach also extends to the vowel points used in Hebrew text. Different vowelizations of the same letters are understood to channel different qualities of divine energy. By visualizing divine names with specific vowel patterns, the practitioner can activate particular divine attributes. For instance, the Tetragrammaton with *cholam* vowels channels energy from Hokhmah, while the same letters with *kamatz* vowels activate Binah.

This letter-based approach to kavvanah represents a distinctive feature of kabbalistic prayer practice, differentiating it from more general concepts of devotional concentration. It suggests that effective prayer depends not merely on emotional sincerity or conceptual understanding but on technical expertise in manipulating the metaphysical properties of sacred language at its most fundamental level.

The central Kavvanah: unification

Among the numerous kavvanot presented in Ma'avar Yabok, one stands as particularly fundamental: the intention to unify "the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence" (*l'yachada kudsha brich hu u-shechintei*). This phrase, derived from Zoharic literature, appears repeatedly throughout the text as the essential kavvanah underlying all religious practice.

This unification refers to the reconciliation of masculine and feminine aspects of divinity, typically represented by the Tetragrammaton (associated with Tiferet and

the masculine principle) and Adonai (associated with Malkhut and the feminine principle). According to kabbalistic understanding, these aspects became partially separated due to cosmic fragmentation caused by human sin, particularly the destruction of the Temple. The primary spiritual task of Jewish religious life involves facilitating their reunification.

Ma'avar Yabok provides detailed instructions for achieving this unification through prayer and ritual. When reciting blessings that contain both divine names (such as "Blessed are You, YHVH our God, King of the universe"), the practitioner should visualize the integration of these names while consciously intending to unite the divine masculine and feminine. This visualization typically involves seeing the letters of the two names intertwining or overlapping, creating a unified divine presence.

The text emphasizes that this unification is not merely conceptual but has actual metaphysical consequences. When properly executed, it draws down divine abundance through the restored channel between Tiferet and Malkhut, benefiting both upper and lower worlds. Conversely, failure to maintain this kavvanah during prayer can result in what kabbalistic literature calls "cutting the shoots" (*kitzutz baneti'ot*)—a disruption of proper cosmic flow that strengthens the forces of judgment.

The central importance of this unifying kavvanah reflects the fundamentally theurgic nature of kabbalistic prayer. Unlike prayer traditions that emphasize petition or personal devotion, the kabbalistic approach presented in Ma'avar Yabok positions human religious consciousness as an active force in maintaining cosmic harmony. Through proper kavvanah, humans participate directly in the restoration of divine wholeness, serving as agents of cosmic repair (*tikkun*).

This unification kavvanah takes on special significance during transitions between life and death. At the deathbed, proper execution of this kavvanah creates a protected pathway for the soul's ascent, ensuring that it passes safely through the various cosmic levels without interference from negative forces. After death, continued application of this kavvanah through prayers for the deceased helps elevate the soul to its proper resting place.

Ma'avar Yabok connects this unification with the biblical narrative of Jacob crossing the Yabok River, which serves as the book's central metaphor. Just as Jacob's wrestling with the angel at the Yabok represented a unification of earthly and divine realms, proper kavvanah during life transitions facilitates the soul's crossing between physical and spiritual existence.

The text also relates this unification to the cosmic marriage between God and Israel, drawing on imagery from Song of Songs. The soul's departure from the body is likened to the bride's joyful reunion with her beloved, transforming death from a fearful separation into a loving homecoming. This nuptial imagery softens the potentially frightening aspects of death, presenting it instead as the fulfillment of the soul's deepest longing for divine union.

In practical terms, Ma'avar Yabok instructs religious functionaries to maintain this unifying kavvanah throughout all aspects of care for the sick and dying. Even seemingly mundane activities like washing the deceased or reciting psalms should be performed with conscious awareness of facilitating divine unification. This infusion of cosmic significance into practical care reflects the text's integration of mystical consciousness with communal religious responsibility.

Kavvanah and the Four Worlds

The kavvanah system presented in Ma'avar Yabok operates within the framework of the four kabbalistic worlds: Atzilut (Emanation), Beriah (Creation), Yetzirah (Formation), and Asiyah (Action). These worlds represent progressively denser levels of divine manifestation, from the most sublime (Atzilut) to the most concrete (Asiyah). Human consciousness, through properly directed kavvanah, can navigate these worlds, creating effects at different cosmic levels.

Berechia explains that different prayers and rituals naturally correspond to different worlds. Simple recitation of words without kavvanah remains limited to Asiyah, the physical world of action. Basic understanding of prayer meaning elevates consciousness to Yetzirah, the world of formation associated with emotion and speech. Deeper contemplation of theological concepts accesses Beriah, the world of pure intellect and divine throne. The highest kavvanah, involving unification of divine names, can reach Atzilut, the world of pure divine emanation where the sefirot themselves reside.

The text emphasizes that effective prayer should ideally activate all four worlds simultaneously, creating a complete circuit of divine energy. This multi-level engagement requires sophisticated kavvanah that addresses the specific qualities of each world:

- For Asiyah: Proper physical actions and verbal articulation
- For Yetzirah: Emotional engagement and visualization of angelic forces
- For Beriah: Intellectual comprehension of theological concepts
- For Atzilut: Contemplation of divine names and their unifications

Ma'avar Yabok provides specific guidance for directing kavvanah toward different worlds depending on the prayer's purpose. Prayers for physical healing should emphasize Asiyah and Yetzirah, visualizing divine energy descending through angelic intermediaries into the physical body. Prayers for spiritual elevation, particularly at death, should focus on Beriah and Atzilut, facilitating the soul's ascent through higher realms.

The text also addresses the correspondence between the four worlds and the components of the human soul: nefesh (vital soul) corresponds to Asiyah, ruach (spirit) to Yetzirah, neshamah (higher soul) to Beriah, and the highest soul levels (chayah and yechidah) to Atzilut. This correspondence creates a direct link between cosmic structure and human spiritual composition, allowing properly directed kavvanah to affect specific soul components.

In deathbed contexts, Ma'avar Yabok explains that death involves the progressive separation of these soul components, with each returning to its corresponding world. The nefesh remains near the grave in Asiyah, the ruach ascends to Yetzirah, and the neshamah to Beriah, while the highest aspects may reach Atzilut. Proper kavvanah during death rituals facilitates this orderly separation and ascension, ensuring that each soul component reaches its appropriate destination.

The four-world framework also informs Ma'avar Yabok's approach to prayer texts. Biblical verses are understood to contain multiple levels of meaning corresponding to the four worlds, from literal (Asiyah) to mystical (Atzilut). When

reciting these verses, the practitioner should be aware of all levels simultaneously, allowing the text to function as a channel connecting the worlds. This multi-level awareness creates what the text describes as a "complete kavvanah" that maximizes prayer's cosmic efficacy.

This cosmic navigation through kavvanah reflects a sophisticated understanding of prayer as multi-dimensional activity. Unlike more simplistic approaches that emphasize either physical performance or emotional sincerity, Ma'avar Yabok presents prayer as a comprehensive engagement with all levels of reality simultaneously. Through proper kavvanah, the practitioner becomes a cosmic traveler, moving between worlds while remaining physically present in ritual action.

Kavvanah as Tikkun

The ultimate purpose of kavvanah in Ma'avar Yabok is tikkun—the repair or rectification of cosmic fragmentation. Drawing on Lurianic Kabbalah, the text presents human religious consciousness as a powerful tool for restoring harmony to divine realms disrupted by primordial catastrophes and subsequent human sin.

According to this framework, creation involved a contraction of divine light (tzimtzum) followed by an emanation of that light into vessels that subsequently shattered (shevirat ha-kelim). This "breaking of the vessels" scattered divine sparks throughout creation and created a state of cosmic disharmony where divine attributes became separated from one another. Human sin, particularly the sin of Adam and later collective transgressions, further exacerbated this fragmentation.

Ma'avar Yabok positions kavvanah as the primary mechanism through which this fragmentation can be healed. When religious acts are performed with proper intention, they serve to gather scattered divine sparks, reunite separated divine attributes, and restore proper flow between cosmic levels. This restorative function transforms seemingly simple religious actions into profound metaphysical interventions.

The text frequently employs the term "sweetening judgments" (mituk ha-dinim) to describe this transformative process. Divine judgment, associated with the sefirah of Gevurah, becomes problematic when disconnected from the balancing influence of Hesed (loving-kindness). Through proper kavvanah, practitioners can channel the energy of Hesed to "sweeten" or transform harsh judgments into constructive spiritual influences.

This sweetening process has particular relevance in contexts of illness and death, where divine judgment manifests in its most severe form. Ma'avar Yabok provides detailed kavvanot designed to transform the judgment of illness into a purifying spiritual process and the judgment of death into a gentle transition. These kavvanot do not seek to eliminate judgment entirely (which would disrupt cosmic order) but to integrate it harmoniously with divine mercy.

Beyond individual situations, the text presents kavvanah as contributing to the broader cosmic tikkun that will ultimately lead to redemption. Each properly executed prayer or ritual with appropriate kavvanah adds to the collective repair of divine realms, bringing the world incrementally closer to complete restoration. This perspective infuses everyday religious practice with messianic significance, positioning even seemingly minor rituals as contributions to universal redemption.

The communal dimension of tikkun receives particular emphasis in Ma'avar Yabok's approach to kavvanah. While individuals can certainly effect significant spiritual repairs through proper intention, the text repeatedly emphasizes the superior power of communal kavvanah. When ten individuals (a minyan) direct their collective consciousness toward the same spiritual goal, their combined intention creates what the text describes as a "complete structure" (partzuf shalem) capable of generating more comprehensive tikkun.

This is particularly evident in the text's instructions for deathbed and burial rituals, which ideally should be performed with a minyan. The collective kavvanah of the community creates a protective spiritual envelope around the departing soul, facilitating its transition and contributing to broader cosmic repair. Here, communal religious responsibility and mystical efficacy converge, reflecting Ma'avar Yabok's integration of practical care with spiritual potency.

The tikkun dimension of kavvanah also explains the text's emphasis on technical precision in prayer and ritual. Since the goal is actual metaphysical repair rather than merely personal devotion, proper execution becomes crucial. Mispronounced words, omitted passages, or incorrect kavvanot can potentially hinder rather than facilitate cosmic restoration. This explains the meticulous detail with which Ma'avar Yabok describes proper procedure and intention for various rituals, particularly those surrounding death.

At the same time, the text acknowledges that perfect kavvanah remains an aspirational ideal rather than a consistent achievement. It offers reassurance that sincere effort, even with imperfect execution, still contributes positively to cosmic tikkun. This balanced approach combines technical rigor with pastoral sensitivity, recognizing both the objective metaphysical significance of kavvanah and the subjective limitations of human practitioners.

Practical guidance for Kavvanah

While Ma'avar Yabok primarily presents kavvanah as a sophisticated metaphysical system, it also offers practical guidance for developing and maintaining proper intention during prayer and ritual. These practical aspects make the text's mystical teachings accessible to ordinary religious functionaries rather than remaining the exclusive domain of elite kabbalists.

Berechia acknowledges that maintaining consistent kavvanah presents significant challenges, particularly during lengthy prayers or emotionally demanding situations like deathbed attendance. Rather than insisting on unrealistic standards of perpetual mystical consciousness, the text provides pragmatic strategies for managing attention and intention within normal human limitations.

One such strategy involves focusing kavvanah on key moments in prayer rather than attempting to maintain intense concentration throughout. Ma'avar Yabok identifies critical junctures—such as the first blessing of the Amidah, the recitation of the Shema, or the conclusion of kaddish—where kavvanah should be especially concentrated. By prioritizing these moments, practitioners can conserve mental energy while still activating the prayer's essential spiritual mechanisms.

The text also recommends preparatory practices to establish proper kavvanah before engaging in prayer or ritual. These include purifying oneself through ritual

washing, eliminating distracting thoughts through brief meditation, and explicitly articulating one's intention to unify divine names before beginning prayer. These preliminary steps create what the text calls a "gateway of intention" (sha'ar ha-kavvanah) through which subsequent prayers can ascend effectively.

For developing visualization skills crucial to kabbalistic kavvanah, Ma'avar Yabok suggests progressive training. Beginners should start by visualizing individual Hebrew letters, gradually advancing to complete divine names, and eventually to complex unifications involving multiple names with specific vowel points. This graduated approach builds the mental capacity necessary for sophisticated kavvanah without overwhelming novice practitioners.

The text also addresses common obstacles to kavvanah, particularly intrusive thoughts (hirhur) that disturb concentration during prayer. Drawing on earlier pietistic literature, Berechia recommends specific techniques for managing such distractions, including briefly pausing prayer to regain focus, visualizing divine names as a protective shield against foreign thoughts, and channeling wandering attention back to prayer through gentle but persistent effort.

Recognizing the challenge of maintaining kavvanah during emotionally charged situations like deathbed attendance, Ma'avar Yabok provides simplified kavvanot for emergency circumstances. These condensed forms maintain the essential spiritual mechanics while requiring less mental elaboration, making them accessible even during periods of stress or time constraint.

The text emphasizes the importance of studying kabbalistic concepts regularly to internalize the cosmological framework underlying effective kavvanah. Rather than treating kavvanah as a separate mental activity added to prayer, practitioners should develop an integrated consciousness where awareness of cosmic correspondences becomes second nature. This integration allows kavvanah to flow naturally during prayer rather than requiring constant conscious effort.

For communal leaders responsible for guiding others in prayer and ritual, Ma'avar Yabok provides instructional language for teaching kavvanah without overwhelming those unfamiliar with kabbalistic concepts. The text offers simplified explanations of complex mystical ideas, making them accessible to ordinary community members while preserving their essential spiritual function.

Perhaps most significantly, Ma'avar Yabok emphasizes that developing proper kavvanah requires balancing technical knowledge with genuine devotional feeling. While mastering the mechanics of divine names and cosmic correspondences remains important, the text insists that this technical knowledge must be animated by authentic spiritual yearning. True kavvanah emerges from the integration of precise mystical technique with sincere religious sentiment, creating what the text describes as "unified service" (avodah achat).

This practical guidance reflects Ma'avar Yabok's overall approach as a manual for communal religious functionaries rather than an esoteric treatise for elite mystics. By providing accessible strategies for developing kavvanah, the text democratizes kabbalistic practice, making its spiritual potency available to a broader range of practitioners responsible for caring for the sick, dying, and deceased within the community.

Enduring significance of Kavvanah

The system of kavvanah presented in Ma'avar Yabok represents one of the most sophisticated attempts to integrate kabbalistic mysticism with practical Jewish religious life. By providing detailed instructions for directing intention during prayer and ritual, particularly in contexts of illness and death, Aaron Berechia of Modena created a manual that bridged esoteric knowledge and communal responsibility, making the cosmic power of proper intention accessible to religious functionaries beyond elite mystical circles.

The text's emphasis on kavvanah as a transformative force capable of influencing divine realms reflects a profound theological position: human consciousness, properly directed, participates actively in the maintenance and repair of cosmic order. This perspective positions religious practitioners not merely as passive recipients of divine influence but as partners in the ongoing work of creation, capable of "sweetening judgments," facilitating divine unifications, and contributing to universal tikkun.

The technical sophistication of Ma'avar Yabok's kavvanah system—with its detailed instructions for visualizing divine names, contemplating sefirotic correspondences, and navigating cosmic worlds—demonstrates the influence of Lurianic Kabbalah, particularly as transmitted through Italian kabbalistic circles. However, Berechia's innovation lies in making these complex mystical techniques practically applicable within conventional religious settings, especially the communal responsibility of caring for the sick and dying.

The text's integration of metaphysical theory with practical guidance reflects a balanced approach to spiritual practice that acknowledges both the objective cosmic significance of kavvanah and the subjective limitations of human practitioners. Rather than demanding unrealistic levels of mystical consciousness, Ma'avar Yabok provides graduated strategies for developing and maintaining kavvanah within normal human capacities, making its spiritual system accessible beyond elite mystics.

Perhaps most significantly, the kavvanah system presented in Ma'avar Yabok offers a profound response to the existential challenges of illness, suffering, and death. By positioning these experiences within a coherent cosmic framework where proper intention can transform harsh judgment into purifying mercy, the text provides both philosophical meaning and practical tools for navigating life's most difficult transitions. This integration of cosmic significance with pastoral sensitivity represents the text's most enduring contribution to Jewish spiritual tradition.

For contemporary readers, Ma'avar Yabok's kavvanah system offers valuable insights into the relationship between consciousness and religious practice. While its specific cosmological framework may not align with modern scientific understandings, its fundamental recognition of intention as a transformative force in ritual remains relevant across religious traditions. The text's sophisticated approach to directing consciousness during prayer and ritual provides a model for integrating contemplative depth with religious action, regardless of one's specific theological commitments.

The enduring significance of kavvanah as presented in Ma'avar Yabok lies in its affirmation that human intention matters—that the conscious direction of awareness during religious practice affects not only subjective experience but objective spiritual reality. This perspective offers a powerful alternative to both mechanistic

approaches to ritual that emphasize external performance without internal engagement and purely psychological interpretations that reduce religious experience to subjective states without cosmic consequence.

In an age often characterized by fragmented attention and mechanical performance of religious obligations, Ma'avar Yabok's emphasis on kavvanah as the animating principle of effective prayer and ritual provides a valuable corrective. Its vision of religious consciousness as a transformative force capable of influencing both personal experience and cosmic reality offers a compelling model for integrating mystical depth with practical religious life—a model that continues to inspire spiritual seekers across traditions and centuries.

Abbreviations

1. א״א — Arich Anpin (Long Face, a divine configuration in Kabbalah).
2. א״ח — Orach Chaim.
3. א״ס — Ein Sof (Infinite One, a reference to God beyond all attributes).
4. אבגית״ץ — ABGITATZ (first word of the 42-letter Divine Name).
5. אבי״ע — Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah (the four spiritual worlds).
6. אח״כ — After this.
7. אי״ה — God willing.
8. אי״ק — AI”K, a kabbalistic alphanumeric system organizing Hebrew letters.
9. אכי״ר — Amen, so may it be [God’s] will.
10. אנ״ך — Scripture (acronym for Torah, Prophets, and Writings).
11. ארי״ך — Arich Anpin (Long-Faced One, a kabbalistic term for a high divine configuration).
12. ב״ה — Beit haknesset (synagogue).
13. בא״י — In the Land of Israel.
14. בג״ע — In the Garden of Eden.
15. בי״ע — Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah.
16. בי״לאו — Acronym for a blessing formula expressing completion with divine assistance.
17. בנל״ך — Blessed is He.
18. בע״ש — On Sabbath eve.
19. בעה״י — With God’s help.
20. בר״מ — In Ra’aya Mehemna.
21. ברהמ״ז — Birkat HaMazon (Grace After Meals).
22. בשבמל״ו — Baruch Shem Kevod Malchuto Le’olam Va’ed (response to the Shema).
23. ג״ח — Acts of kindness (gemilut chasadim).
24. ג״ע — Garden of Eden.
25. ג״פ — Three times.
26. גגת״מ — Chesed, Gevurah, Tiferet, and Malkhut.
27. ׳גמ — Gemara (Talmud).
28. ד״א — Four cubits.
29. ד״ת — Words of Torah (divrei Torah).
30. דס״מ — Of Samael (angelic being associated with evil).
31. האר״י — The ARI (Rabbi Isaac Luria).
32. הוי״ה — YHVH (Tetragrammaton).
33. ׳דמ — Malkhut (Kingdom), the Divine Feminine.
34. הסמ״ג — Sefer HaMitzvot HaGadol (a comprehensive medieval legal code).

35. הקב״ה — The Holy One, blessed be He.
36. הראב״ד — RABD (Rabbi Abraham ben David).
37. ו״ק — Six Extremities.
38. ואע״י — And by His help.
39. וגו׳ — Etc. (abbreviation indicating familiar text continues).
40. וכו׳ — Etc.
41. ולש״ש — For the sake of Heaven.
42. ז״א — Zeir Anpin (Small-Faced One).
43. ז״את — ZOT (a reference to Malkhut/Shekhinah, the divine feminine presence).
44. זצ״ל — Of blessed memory.
45. זצוק״ל — May the memory of the holy righteous one be a blessing.
46. ח״ב — Chokhmah-Binah.
47. ח״ו — Heaven forbid.
48. חג״ת — Chesed-Gevurah-Tiferet (Kindness-Strength-Beauty).
49. חז״ל — Our Sages of blessed memory.
50. יו״ט — Festivals/holidays.
51. יח״ב — Acronym for a blessing formula.
52. יצ״ה — Evil inclination.
53. יצ״ו — May his Rock keep him and grant him life.
54. יצ״ט — Good inclination.
55. יצה״ר — Evil inclination.
56. ירו׳ — Jerusalem Talmud.
57. כ״י — Community of Israel (Knesset Yisrael).
58. כ״ע — Keter Elyon (Supreme Crown).
59. כי״ר — May it be [Your] will.
60. כמהה״ר — The honorable Rabbi.
61. לעה״ב — In the World to Come.
62. מ״ה — Angel of Death.
63. מ״ל — Mem-Lamed (initials referring to Malkhut/Kingdom).
64. מ״ר — Midrash Rabbah.
65. מט״ט — Metatron (angelic being).
66. מטט׳ — Metatron.
67. ממ״ה — Angel of Death.
68. מרע״ה — Moses our teacher.
69. נ״ה — Netzach and Hod (Victory and Splendor).
70. נ״ש — Sabbath candles.
71. נט״י — Netilat yadayim (ritual hand-washing).
72. נר״ן — Nefesh-Ruach-Neshamah (the three main levels of the soul).
73. נר״נ — Nefesh-ruach-neshamah.
74. ס״א — Sitra Achra (the Other Side).
75. ס״מ — Samael (name of the angel of death).
76. ס״ת — Torah scroll (Sefer Torah).
77. סי׳ — Siman (section/number).
78. עה״ב — The World to Come.

79. עה״ז — This world.
80. עה״ז/עוה״ז — This world.
81. עוה״ב — The World to Come (Olam HaBa).
82. פ״ט — Chapter 9.
83. ק״ק — Holy Community.
84. ק״ש — Kriat Shema (recitation of the Shema prayer).
85. קב״ה — The Holy One, blessed be He.
86. קוב״ה — The Holy One, blessed be He.
87. קק״י — Holy communities.
88. ר״ה — Rosh Hashanah.
89. ר״ח — New moon (Rosh Chodesh).
90. ר״מ — Ra'aya Mehemna (section of the Zohar).
91. ר״ת — Initial letters, acronym.
92. ראב״י — Rabbi Eliezer ben Yaakov.
93. ריב״ל — Rabbi Joshua ben Levi.
94. רע״מ — Ra'aya Mehemna.
95. רשב״י — Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai.
96. ש״מ — Shechiv mera (deathly ill person).
97. שי״ת — The Holy One, blessed be He.
98. שכמ״לו — Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever.
99. ת״ח — Torah scholar.
100. ת״ת — Tiferet.
101. תוב״ב — May it be rebuilt and established speedily in our days.
102. תש״ת — TASHAT (sequence of shofar sounds: tekiah-shevarim-tekiah).

Glossary

1. אִישׁ לְאָהָלוֹ יִשְׂרָאֵל — To your tents, O Israel (phrase from the rebellion against the House of David in 1 Kings 12:16).
2. אִסְרוּ־חַג בַּעֲבֹתִים — Bind the festival sacrifice with cords.
3. אֵם עַל בָּנִים — Mother with children (idiom for complete destruction).
4. אֶהְיֶה אֲשֶׁר אֶהְיֶה — I AM THAT I AM.
5. אֶחֱטָם — I will hold back/restrain.
6. אֶרֶץ חַיִּים — Land of the living.
7. אַהֲבָה רַבָּה וּבְאַהֲבָה זוּטָא — Great love and lesser love (kabbalistic terms for different levels of divine love).
8. אַיֶּלֶת הַשַּׁחַר — Doe of the dawn.
9. אַכְזָב — Deceptive/unreliable.
10. אַפִּרְיוֹן — Royal pavilion.
11. אַרְצוֹת הַחַיִּים — Lands of the living.
12. אָזְלַת יָד — Power is gone.
13. אבגית"ץ — ABGITATZ (first word of the 42-letter divine name).
14. אבי אבות הטומאה — Primary source of impurity.
15. אביזרייהו — Their accessories/related matters.
16. אבני שיש טהור — Pure marble stones.
17. אגדות — Aggadot.
18. אגרא דבי טמיא שתיקותא — The reward of the house of mourning is silence.
19. אדם דאצילות — Adam of Atzilut (Adam of the World of Emanation).
20. אדם העליון — Supernal Adam.
21. אדם קדמון — Primordial Adam.
22. אדרת האזינו — Idra Ha'azinu (a section of the Zohar containing mystical teachings).
23. אהבה זוטא — Lesser love.
24. אהבה רבה — Great love.
25. אויר המחכים — Enlightening atmosphere.
26. אור גנוז — Hidden light.
27. אור האצילות — Light of Emanation.
28. אור החוזר — Reflected light.
29. אור החצון — External light.
30. אור המתהפך — Reflected light.
31. אור הקדום — Primordial Light.
32. אור השכינה — Light of the Divine Presence.

33. אור ישר וחוזר — Direct and reflected light.
34. אור מקיף — Encompassing light.
35. אור פנימי — Inner light.
36. אור קדמון — Primordial Light.
37. אור ראשון — Primordial light.
38. אורות ימיניים ושמאליים — Lights from the right and the left.
39. אורות שבאצילות — Lights of the World of Emanation.
40. אושפיזין עילאין — Supernal guests (refers to the seven biblical figures who spiritually visit the sukkah).
41. אושפיזין קדישין — Holy guests.
42. אות ברית — Sign of the covenant.
43. אותיות לפופות — Wrapped/curved letters.
44. אותיות פורחות וגוילים נשרפים — Flying letters and burning parchments.
45. אזובי קיר — Wall moss/hyssop (metaphor for ordinary people).
46. אזנים כריית לי — Ears You have opened for me.
47. אחורי זעיר לנוקביה — The back of Zeir Anpin and its feminine counterpart.
48. אחורים של אלהים — The 'back' of Elohim (a kabbalistic concept referring to external aspects of divine judgment).
49. אידרת האזינו — Idra Ha'azinu (a section of the Zohar).
50. אילן החיים — Tree of Life.
51. אילן עץ החיים — Tree of Life.
52. אילנא דחיי — Tree of Life.
53. אילנא דמותא — Tree of Death.
54. אימא עילאה — Supernal Mother (the divine emanation of Binah/Understanding).
55. אישים — Ishim (fiery beings, a category of angels).
56. אכתריאל י״ה ה׳ צבאות — Achtariel Yah YHVH Tzeva'ot (divine name).
57. אכתריאל יה ה׳ צבאות — Achtariel Yah YHVH Tzeva'ot.
58. אל אלהים — El Elohim (divine name combining mercy and judgment).
59. אלהים דמרגלאן דנהיר — The god of shining pearls.
60. אלפא ביתא רבתי בינונית וזעירא — Large, medium, and small alphabets.
61. אמא עלאה דמקננא בבורסיא — Supernal Mother who nests in the Throne.
62. אנשי החיל — Strong men.
63. אסף ההודי — Asaf the Indian.
64. אספקלריאה דנהרא — Illuminating lens.
65. אספקלריאה המאירה — Luminous speculum (clear prophetic vision).
66. אספקלריאה שאינה מאירה — Non-luminous speculum (unclear prophetic vision).
67. אצילות, בריאה, יצירה, עשיה — Atzilut, Beriah, Yetzirah, Asiyah (the four spiritual worlds).
68. אצילת נשמתו — Emanation of one's soul.
69. אקונין — Image/icon.
70. ארבע חיות גדולות — Four great celestial creatures.
71. ארבע מחנות שכינה — Four camps of the Divine Presence.
72. ארבע מיתות ב״ד — Four court-imposed death penalties.
73. ארבע מיתות בית דין — Four court-imposed death penalties.
74. ארבע פני המרכבה — Four faces of the Divine Chariot.

75. ארבע רתיכין — Four celestial chariots.
76. ארבעה אבות נזיקין — Four principal categories of damages.
77. ארבעה אנפין — Four faces.
78. ארון הברית העליונה — The supernal Ark of the Covenant.
79. ארך אנפין — Arich Anpin (the Long-Faced One).
80. ארץ העליונה — Supernal earth.
81. ארקא — Arka (one of the seven earths in Jewish mysticism).
82. אש שחורה על גבי אש לבנה — Black fire upon white fire.
83. אשם נפשו — Guilt-offering of his soul.
84. אתקלס עילאה — The Supreme One is praised.
85. בְּאַשְׁמֻרוֹת — In the night watches.
86. בְּאוֹר הַחַיִּים — In the light of life.
87. בְּגֵיא צַלְמָוֶת — Valley of the shadow of death.
88. בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי נַפְשִׁי — When my soul faints within me.
89. בְּהִתְעַטֵּף עָלַי רוּחִי — When my spirit grows faint within me.
90. בְּיָדְךָ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי — Into Your hand I commit my spirit.
91. בְּיָדְךָ עִתֹּתָי — My times are in Your hand.
92. בְּנֵי עֲלִיָּה — Elevated Souls.
93. בְּרִית קוֹדֶשׁ שֶׁבִּבְשָׂרוֹ — Holy covenant in his flesh.
94. בְּרִיתִי שָׁלוֹם — My covenant of peace.
95. בִּלַּע הַמָּוֶת לָנֶצַח — He will swallow up death forever.
96. בַּסָּךְ — In the throng/procession.
97. בַּר מִינָּן — God forbid.
98. בָּמוֹתֵימוֹ — Their high places.
99. בָּמוֹתַי — My high places.
100. בור תַּחְתִּיוֹת — Lowest pit, deepest dungeon.
101. בּוֹרֵא נִיב שְׂפָתָיִם — Creating the fruit of the lips.
102. באגרא דתעניתא — At the expense of fasting (the spiritual reward of fasting).
103. באדרא — In the Idra.
104. באידרא — In the Idra.
105. באספקלריא המאירה — Illuminating lens.
106. באר מיין נביעין — Well of flowing waters (metaphor for activated divine feminine energy).
107. בארץ בוקה מבוקה ומבולקה — In a land laid waste, utterly emptied and plundered.
108. באתר דאצטריך — In the place where it is needed.
109. באתר דליכא למיחש לאנצויי — In a place where there is no concern for quarreling.
110. בבואה דבבואה — Shadow of a shadow (reflection of an image).
111. בבטן האם העליונה — In the womb of the Supernal Mother.
112. בגדולה וגבורה — In Gedulah and Gevurah.
113. בגדי הקדושה — Garments of holiness (metaphor for spiritual existence after death).
114. בגימטרי״א ב״ן — With the numerical value of 52 (BaN).
115. בגין דיתרבי ויתוסף רבות קדושה — In order that holiness may increase and be added.
116. בדביקתא ברעותא באחדוותא חדא — In attachment, in willingness, in singular unity.
117. בדרועא וירכא ימינא — On the right arm and thigh.
118. בדרועא וירכא שמאלא — On the left arm and thigh.

119. בדרועא ימינא — In the right arm (kabbalistic reference to the side of mercy).
120. בדרועא שמאלא — In the left arm (kabbalistic reference to the side of judgment).
121. בוצינין מתדלקן ונהורין נהרין — Lamps are kindled and lights shine forth.
122. בוצינין עילאין — Supernal lights.
123. בור שאון — Pit of destruction.
124. בחינת האבות — Aspect of the Patriarchs.
125. בחינת הנשמה שבו — Aspect of the neshamah within him.
126. בטישת האורות — Impact/striking of lights.
127. ביחוד שם ג׳ — On the unification of the third name.
128. ביחוד שם ה׳ — On the unification of the fifth name.
129. בילת׳ עילאה — Supernal canopy.
130. בינה בגבורה — Binah within Gevurah.
131. בינה בחכמה — Binah within Chokhmah.
132. ביסום הגבורות — Sweetening of the powers of judgment.
133. ביסום הדין — Sweetening of judgment.
134. ביסום התפלה — Sweetening through prayer.
135. ביסום מדת הדין — Sweetening the attribute of judgment.
136. בית דין עליון ובית דין תחתון — Upper court and lower court.
137. בית עילאה — Supernal house.
138. ביתא עילאה קדישא — Holy supernal house.
139. במעדנות כימה — With the chains of Orion.
140. בן גילו — One born under the same astrological sign.
141. בנוקבא דתהומא רבא — In the opening of the great abyss.
142. בני השפחות — Children of the handmaids (mystical reference to lower spiritual forces).
143. בני רשף — Sons of the flame.
144. בני תמורה — Children of substitution (offspring conceived with improper thoughts).
145. בסום הדין — Sweetening of judgment (kabbalistic concept of transforming divine severity into mercy).
146. בעל העקדה — The author of the Akedah (Rabbi Isaac Arama).
147. בעל הרצון — Master of Will.
148. בעלי בחירה — Possessors of free will.
149. בעלי הדין — Forces of judgment.
150. בעלי קרי — Masters of chance/those affected by ritual impurity.
151. בעלמא דהדיוט — In the realm of ordinary mortals.
152. בעלמא דיליה — In His own realm.
153. בפולסי דנורא — With lashes of fire.
154. בר בי רב דחד יומא — A sage of a single day.
155. בר נפלי — Son of the fallen.
156. ברא מזכי אבא — A son brings merit to his father.
157. ברית העליון — Supernal covenant.
158. ברית כרותה לשפתים — Covenant made with the lips.
159. ברתיכוהי — His chariots.
160. בת עין העליונה — Supernal pupil.
161. בתיאובתא שלימתא — With complete desire.

162. ג״ח העליונים — Celestial acts of loving-kindness.
163. ג״ע עליון ותחתון — Upper and lower Garden of Eden.
164. ג״ע של מטה — Lower Garden of Eden.
165. ג׳ אבות חג״ת — Three Patriarchs—Chesed, Gevurah, and Tiferet.
166. גַּחֲלֵי רְתָמִים — Coals of broom wood.
167. גַּלְגַּלּוֹתָי נוּר דָּלֵק — Its wheels burning fire.
168. גַּן יְחוּדֶךָ — Garden of Your unity.
169. גַּן עֵדֶן עֶלְיוֹן — Supernal Garden of Eden (the higher level of paradise in kabbalistic thought).
170. גַּן עֵדֶן תַּחְתּוֹן וְעֶלְיוֹן — Lower and upper Garden of Eden.
171. גּוֹל עַל יְהוָה — Commit to the LORD (lit. roll onto the LORD).
172. גָּלְמִי — My embryonic form.
173. גבולי אלכסון — Diagonal boundaries.
174. גבורה עליונה — Supernal Gevurah (divine attribute of Strength/Judgment).
175. גבורות העליונות — Supernal powers of severity.
176. גבורות חיצונות — External powers of severity/judgment.
177. גוזי — My deliverer/protector.
178. גולגלתא חיוורא קדישא סתימא — Holy, concealed white skull.
179. גיהנם תחתון — Lower Gehinnom.
180. גימטריא — Gematria (Hebrew numerology).
181. גינת אגוז — Ginat Egoz (a kabbalistic text on the mystical properties of Hebrew letters).
182. גירא בעינא דשטנא — An arrow in Satan's eye (a provocative phrase).
183. גלגול מחילות — Rolling through caves.
184. גלגל האדום — The red wheel (a mystical reference to Malkhut in its aspect of judgment).
185. גלגל ערבות — Sphere of Aravot.
186. גלגלי התבונה — Celestial spheres of the astronomical configuration.
187. גן עדן (ג״ע) — Garden of Eden.
188. גן עדן עליון ותחתון — Upper and lower Garden of Eden.
189. גן עדן של מטה — Lower Garden of Eden.
190. גן עדן של מעלה — Supernal Garden of Eden.
191. גן עדן תחתון — Lower Garden of Eden.
192. גנת אגוז — Garden of Nuts.
193. גנתא דארעא ודרקיעא — Garden of earth and heaven.
194. גרדיני נמוסין — Enforcers of the law.
195. גרירת עצמות — Dragging of bones.
196. ד׳ מדרגות הנשמה — Four levels of the soul.
197. ד׳ מחנות שכינה — Four camps of the Divine Presence.
198. ד׳ פני המרכבה — Four faces of the Divine Chariot.
199. דְּבִיר קָדְשֶׁךָ — Your holy sanctuary.
200. דְּבַקוּתָא דְרוּחָא בְּרוּחָא — Cleaving of spirit to spirit.
201. דִּינָא יְתִב וְסִפְרִין פְּתִיחוּ — Judgment was set and books were opened.
202. דַּק מְחֻסְפָּס — Fine flake-like substance.
203. דַּרְגִין דְּכוּרְסְיָא — Levels of the Throne.
204. דְּעָבוּ כְּאֵשׁ קוֹצִים — They were extinguished like a fire of thorns.
205. דבקות רוח החיים הפנימי — Cleaving of the inner life-breath.

206. דבקותא דנפשא בשכינתא — Cleaving of the soul to the Divine Presence.
207. דברי יחוד וטהרה וקדושה — Words of unification, purification, and sanctification.
208. דו פרצופין — Dual aspects/faces.
209. דובב שפתי ישנים — Making the lips of the sleepers speak.
210. דודין תתאין — Lower beloved ones.
211. דחשיבי למבעי רחמי לכולי דרא — They are considered worthy of seeking mercy for the entire generation.
212. דידע למחרז וידע למקדש — Who knew how to compose verse and how to craft sacred words.
213. דיהיב חלישותא בשיפוהי דרתיכא — Causes weakness in the limbs of the Divine Chariot.
214. דיוטא זעירא — Smallest dimension/lowest level.
215. דיוקן נשמתו — Image of his soul.
216. דיוקן סבא קדישא — Image of the Holy Elder.
217. דיוקנא דזעיר — Image of Zeir Anpin.
218. דיוקנא דמלכא — Image of the King.
219. דיוקנאות — Soul images.
220. דיוקני הנשמות — Soul-images.
221. דיוקנים — Configurations.
222. דיוקנין דמלין דחכמתא — Images of matters of wisdom.
223. דין אשא דגרמי — Judgment of the fire of the bones.
224. דין הגבורה — Judgment of Gevurah.
225. דין הקבר — Judgment of the grave.
226. דינא דגרמי — Causative damages.
227. דינא דקברא — Judgment of the grave.
228. דינים החיצונים — External judgments.
229. דינים החצונים — External judgments.
230. דינים קדושים — Holy judgments.
231. דיקנא חיוורא — White Beard (a divine configuration in Kabbalah).
232. דיקנא יקירא דאריך — Precious beard of Arich Anpin.
233. דכדוכה של נפש — Crushing point of the soul.
234. דכר ונוקבא — Male and female (masculine and feminine spiritual principles).
235. דמותו של מעלה — His heavenly image.
236. דמים — Bloodguilt.
237. דמשתעי בלשון חכמת הנבואה — As expressed in the language of prophetic wisdom.
238. דרגא דאצטריך לאתקנא — Level which needs to be rectified.
239. דרגין דכורסייא — Levels of the Divine Throne.
240. דרועא דשמאלא — Left arm (kabbalistic reference to Gevurah).
241. דרועא וירכא וגופא — Arm, thigh, and body (kabbalistic references to divine attributes).
242. דררא דממונא — Monetary matters/financial obligations.
243. דשכינה קדמא ואתיא — For the Divine Presence precedes and arrives.
244. ה״א העליונה — Upper Hei.
245. ה״א עילאה — Upper Hei.
246. ה״א תתאה — Lower Hei.
247. הֶבֶל הַתִּנּוֹקוֹת — The breath of schoolchildren.
248. הִסְתּוֹפֵף — To be a doorkeeper.

249. הֵיכָל הַנֹּגַהּ — Palace of Brightness.
250. הַגִּתִּית — The Gittith.
251. הַגּוֹאֵל — The Redeemer.
252. הַחֲפֵצִים לְיִרְאָה אֶת שְׁמֶךָ — Who desire to fear Your name.
253. הַמַּלְאָךְ הַגּוֹאֵל — The Angel, the Redeemer.
254. הַשֹּׁמְרִים הַבְלֵי־שָׁוְא — Those who regard vain idols.
255. הָעֲרָעָר — The destitute/stripped bare.
256. האורים ותומים — Urim and Thummim.
257. האין העליון — The Supernal Nothingness.
258. האין סוף — The Ein Sof (Infinite One).
259. הבינה — Binah (Understanding).
260. הבל פה — Breath of the mouth.
261. הבל שיש בו חטא — Vanity that leads to sin.
262. הבל״א דגר״מי — Breath of the bones.
263. הבלא דגרמי — Vapor of the bones.
264. הגשימו — Materialized [God].
265. הוי״ה אהי״ה אדנו״ת — YHVH, Ehyeh, Adonut (Divine Names).
266. הוי״ה אחד ושמו אחד — The Lord is One and His Name is One.
267. הוי״ה בארבע גדפין אדנ״י — The Tetragrammaton with the four wings of Adonai.
268. הוי״ה ואדנ״ות — YHVH and ADNY (divine names).
269. הוי״ה ואדנ״י — YHVH and ADNY.
270. הוי״ה ואדנו״ת — YHVH and ADNY (divine names).
271. הוי״ה נקודה חולם — The divine name YHVH with the cholam vowel pointing.
272. הויה אהיה אדנות — YHVH, Ehyeh, Adonut (three divine names).
273. הויה ואדנות משולבים — YHVH and ADNY interwoven (combination of two divine names).
274. הויה חירק — YHVH with the chirik vowel point.
275. הויה נקודה סגול — The divine name YHVH with segol vowel points.
276. הויה נקודה שו״א — Divine name YHVH with sheva vowel pointing.
277. הויה קדושה — Holy existence.
278. הויות החסד — Divine Names of Mercy.
279. הויות הקדושות — Holy Divine Names.
280. הויות וכנוים — The Tetragrammaton and divine epithets.
281. הזלזלים — Tendrils (metaphorically referring to negative forces).
282. החום הטבעי — Natural heat.
283. החכמה סתימא עילאה — The supernal hidden Wisdom.
284. היחוד והברכה והקדושה — Unification, blessing, and holiness.
285. היחוד עליון — Supernal unification.
286. היכל אהבה — Palace of Love.
287. היכל החיצונים — Palace of the external forces.
288. היכל הרצון — Chamber of Will.
289. היכל לבנת הספיר — Palace of the Sapphire Brick.
290. היכל קדש הקדשים — Chamber of the Holy of Holies.
291. היכל שני של ההמורות — Second chamber of the Exchanges.
292. היכלות היצירה — Chambers of Formation.

293. היכלות התמורה — Palaces of exchange.
294. היכלות עליונות שבבריאה — Upper Palaces of the World of Creation.
295. היכלות רבתי והיכלות זוטרתי — Greater Palaces and Lesser Palaces (ancient mystical texts).
296. היכלות שביצירה — Palaces of the World of Formation.
297. היכלי הקדושה — Palaces of Holiness.
298. היכלי התמורות — Palaces of Exchange.
299. היסוד — Yesod (Foundation, the divine attribute of cosmic unity).
300. הכסאות עליונות — Supernal Thrones.
301. הכרת — Spiritual excision.
302. הכתר — Keter (Crown).
303. הלולא דאורייתא — Celebration of Torah.
304. המאציל העליון — The Supreme Emanator.
305. המבסם דיני גהינם — Sweetening the judgments of Gehenna.
306. המזבח יצרו — Sacrifices his evil inclination.
307. המזל עליון — The supreme destiny/mazal.
308. המחשבה העליונה — The supernal thought.
309. המחשבה התחתונה — The lower thought.
310. המיימינים והמשמאילים — Those on the right and those on the left.
311. המלאך והמזל והמשרת של היום — The angel, zodiac sign, and celestial minister of the day.
312. המלך הקדוש והמלך המשפט — The Holy King and the King of Judgment.
313. המלכין קדמאין — Primordial kings.
314. המענה ומסגף עצמו — One who afflicts and mortifies himself.
315. המפקיד נשמתו — One who entrusts/deposits their soul.
316. המרגלא — The mystical formula.
317. המשחיתים זרעם — Those who destroy their seed (reference to masturbation or spilling seed).
318. המתקת הדינים — Sweetening of judgments.
319. המתקת הדינין — Sweetening of judgments.
320. הנהגת הרחמים — Governance of Mercy.
321. הסלונות — Thorns (spiritual pathways that conduct impurity).
322. העדר קצתי — Partial absence.
323. העדר תכליתי — Complete absence.
324. העובר על מדותיו — One who overcomes his natural tendencies.
325. העשי״ן והלאוי״ן שבסמ״ג — The positive and negative commandments in the Semag.
326. הפנים העליונים — Supernal aspects/divine countenance.
327. הפראים — The wild ones (referring to certain spiritual entities).
328. הצדיק עליון — The Supernal Righteous One.
329. הצינורות עליונים — Supernal channels.
330. הציצו — Gazed improperly.
331. הקומה השלמה העליונה — The complete supernal structure (kabbalistic reference to the divine emanations).
332. הקליפה — Kelipah (negative spiritual shell/force).
333. הקליפות — Kelipot (negative forces/shells).
334. הקליר — Kallir.
335. הרהורין ומחשבתין דהבלי עלמא — Thoughts and contemplations of worldly vanities.

336. הרוחות פורחים — The spirits fly away (referring to harmful spiritual entities that scatter when mourners pause).
337. הרצון הקדמון — Primordial Will.
338. השושבין — The attendant (literally 'groomsman', mystically representing one who facilitates divine unions).
339. השכבה — Hashkavah (prayer for the repose of the soul).
340. השכל הפועל — Active Intellect.
341. השעשוע — Divine delight.
342. השרשת הגבורות — Embedding of the powers of judgment.
343. השתלשלות — Emanation/chain of transmission.
344. התבודדות — Hitbodedut (spiritual seclusion/isolation).
345. התעוררות התחתונים — Awakening from below.
346. התעוררות תחתון — Awakening from below.
347. התפשטות ווין — Extension of Vavs.
348. התרנגול הבר — The wild/celestial rooster.
349. התרת נדרים — Annulment of vows.
350. התרת קללות — Annulment of curses.
351. ו׳ קצוות — Six extremities.
352. וְאַנְוֵהוּ — And I will glorify Him.
353. וְהֶתָּחוֹלֵל — Wait patiently/be brought forth in birth pangs.
354. וְיִדְגּוּ לָרֹב — May they proliferate abundantly like fish.
355. וְעַל רֹאשִׁי שְׁכִינַת אֵל — And the Divine Presence above my head.
356. וְתָסֵךְ עָלֵימוֹ — And You will shelter them.
357. וידוי — Confession.
358. וַיִּנָּחֶם יְהוָה — And the LORD relented.
359. וַיָּרֶם קֶרֶן — He has raised up a horn.
360. וַתִּתְעַטֵּף — Is overwhelmed/enveloped.
361. ואתגלימו כדיוקנא דהוו בהאי עלמא — And they appear in the same form they had in this world.
362. ובנ״ה — And in Netzach and Hod.
363. והנה טוב מאד זה מות — 'And behold, it was very good'—this refers to death (rabbinic interpretation of Genesis 1:31).
364. וים עליון ישים כמרקחה — And will make the upper sea churn like a boiling pot.
365. וכפר — Make atonement.
366. ז׳ הבלים — Seven breaths/emanations.
367. ז׳ עיני ה׳ — Seven eyes of the Lord.
368. ז׳ צורות קדושות — Seven holy forms.
369. ז׳ שמות של אנא בכח — Seven names from the Ana Bekoach prayer.
370. זְבֶל קָדְשֶׁךָ — Your holy habitation.
371. זְרוֹעוֹת וְיַרְכִּין מִסִּטְרָא דִּקְדֻשָּׁה — Arms and thighs of the side of holiness.
372. זִבְחֵי צֶדֶק — Sacrifices of righteousness.
373. זווג הספירות — Union of the sefirot.
374. זווג העליון — Supernal union.
375. זווג תחתון — Earthly union.
376. זווגא דמטרוניתא — Union of the Divine Feminine.
377. זווגא דמלכא ומטרוניתא — Union of the King and Queen.

378. זווגא עילאה — Supernal union.
379. זיעת החיות — Sweat of the living creatures (mystical reference to the intense divine energy of angelic beings).
380. זכוכית לבנה — Clear glass.
381. זעיר אנפין — Zeir Anpin (the Lesser Countenance, a divine configuration).
382. זקוקין דנור ובעורין דאשא — Fiery sparks and burning flames.
383. זקן עליון — Supernal beard.
384. זרועות וירכין מסטרא דקדושה — Arms and thighs of the side of holiness.
385. זרקא — Zarka (a cantillation mark symbolizing ascent).
386. ח״ר ד״ל — Contends with and subdues.
387. חֶבְלֵי שְׁאוֹל — Cords of Sheol.
388. חֲדָלִי — My cessation/passing.
389. חֶזְיוֹן מַאֲמָרוֹ — Vision of His word.
390. חַבְלֵי מָשִׁיחַ — Birth pangs of the Messiah.
391. חָטָאתִי עָוִיתִי פָּשַׁעְתִּי — I have sinned, I have transgressed, I have rebelled.
392. חֹנֶה מַלְאַךְ־יְיָ — The angel of the LORD encamps.
393. חבוט הקבר — Chibut HaKever (Beating of the Grave).
394. חביבין יסורין — Sufferings are beloved (a rabbinic concept that afflictions have spiritual value).
395. חגר על סומא — A lame person upon a blind one.
396. חוט של חסד — Thread of divine kindness.
397. חוטמא עילאה — Chotma Ila'ah (Supernal Nose).
398. חומות ירושלים — Walls of Jerusalem.
399. חופות הצדיקים — Canopies of the righteous.
400. חותם המתהפך — Reversing seal.
401. חטא עון ופשע — Transgression, iniquity, and willful sin.
402. חיבוט הקבר — Chibut HaKever (Beating of the Grave).
403. חיה ויחידה — Chayah and yechidah (the fourth and fifth levels of the soul).
404. חיות דכורסייא — Beasts of the Throne (the four angelic beings supporting the Divine Throne).
405. חיות האצילות — Life-force of Atzilut (Emanation).
406. חיות הקדש — Holy Chayot.
407. חיזו דשכינתא — Vision of the Divine Presence.
408. חייתא עילאה קדישא — Holy supernal life-force.
409. חכמה תתאה — Lower Wisdom.
410. חכמת החבלה — Wisdom of Kabbalah (literally 'wisdom of the cable/bond').
411. חלב האם — Milk of the Mother (a kabbalistic term for the divine attribute of Binah/Understanding).
412. חלוץ עצמות — Resurrection of the bones.
413. חלוקא דרבנן — Chaluka D'Rabbanan (Scholarly Garment).
414. חליצות — Strengthening/revitalization.
415. חמה עזה — Intense judgment.
416. חמצו והשאור שבעסתו — His leaven and the sourdough in his dough.
417. חמרא דימא — Donkey of the sea (possibly referring to a sea creature or metaphorically to someone with limited understanding).
418. חמש גבורות שבבינה — Five powers of Binah.

419. חניקא כריכא בצואריה דשד — A noose wrapped around the neck of the demon.
420. חסד ואמת — Loving kindness and truth.
421. חסד שבגבורה — Kindness within strength.
422. חפיפת הביצים — Rubbing of eggs.
423. חצר מות — Court of Death.
424. חצרמות — Chatzarmaveth.
425. חקירה — Philosophical investigation.
426. חרב פיפיות — Double-edged sword (lit. 'sword of mouths').
427. חרכים — Lattices.
428. חרם דאשא דגרמי — Burning fire of the bones.
429. חשמל — Chashmal (divine luminous substance).
430. חתן עם כלתו — The bridegroom with his bride (mystical reference to divine unification).
431. ט׳ קבין — Nine kav.
432. טַל אוֹרוֹת — Dew of light.
433. טוֹב הַצָּפוּן — Hidden goodness.
434. טומאת אהל — Tent impurity.
435. טיול ושעשוע — Spiritual journeying and delight.
436. טל אורות עליונים — Supernal dew of lights.
437. טל התחיה — Dew of resurrection.
438. טל תחיית המתים — Dew of resurrection.
439. טפת הזכר וטפת הנקבה — Drop of the male and drop of the female.
440. י״ב אחד — The twelve [tribes] of 'One'.
441. י״ג מדות דאריך — Thirteen Attributes of Arikh Anpin.
442. י״ג מדות עליונות — Thirteen Supernal Attributes (of divine mercy).
443. י״ג שערים — Thirteen gates.
444. י״ג תקוני דיקנא דאריך — Thirteen rectifications of the beard of Arich Anpin.
445. י״ג תקוני דיקני — Thirteen rectifications of the beard.
446. יְכַהֵן — Adorns himself (with priestly connotations).
447. יְשׁוּעוֹת פָּנָיו — Salvation of His face/countenance.
448. יִחוּדְךָ — Your unity.
449. יִצְרִי — My inclination (particularly the evil inclination).
450. יְיַחֵד לְבָבֵנוּ — May our heart be unified.
451. יֵצֶר טוֹב עַל יֵצֶר הָרָע — Good inclination over evil inclination.
452. יַחֲלִין — Strengthen/invigorate.
453. יַעֲרֹף — Drop/drip.
454. יוֹרְדֵי בוֹר — Those who descend to the grave.
455. יאכ״ו — YAKH'U.
456. יגר שהדותא — Heap of witness.
457. ידו״ד אדנ״י — YHVH-ADNY.
458. יה״ו שבשם — The letters yod-hei-vav of the divine Name.
459. יהא שמיה רבא בעלמא די ברא כרעותיה — May His great Name be magnified in the world that He created according to His will.
460. יו״ד ה״א שבשם — The letters yod-hei of the divine Name.
461. יו״ד שבשם הקדוש — The letter yod of the holy Name.

462. יוֹנַת אִלֶּם רְחוֹקִים — A Silent Dove of Distant Places.
463. יובלא — Jubilee.
464. יומא דהלולא דעילאי — Wedding day of the supernal ones.
465. יורדי דומה — Those who descend to silence.
466. יזקוף עשר אצבעותיו — Raise his ten fingers.
467. יחוד ארבע אותיות השם — Unification of the four letters of the Divine Name.
468. יחוד הקדושה — Unification of holiness.
469. יחוד קב״ה ושכינתיה — Unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence.
470. יחוד קוב״ה ושכינתיה — Unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence.
471. יחוד קודשא בריך הוא ושכינתיה — Unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence.
472. יחוד שם שמים — Unification of the Divine Name.
473. יחוד תרין דודין עילאין — Unification of the two supernal beloveds.
474. יחוד תתחתון — Lower unification.
475. יחודא דקב״ה ושכינתיה — Unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Divine Presence.
476. יחודי אהב״ה — Unifications of love.
477. יחודים ותקונים — Unifications and rectifications.
478. ייחודים — Unifications.
479. יין המשומר — Preserved wine (metaphor for spiritual reward in the World to Come).
480. יכוון — Should intend/focus intention.
481. יכוין — Direct one's intention/focus (kavvanah).
482. יכין לבעז — Jachin to Boaz (pillars of Solomon's Temple, representing cosmic balance).
483. ימי רע דיצה״ר — Evil days of the evil inclination.
484. ימין ושמאל — Right and Left (representing Mercy and Judgment).
485. ימינא עלאה — Supernal right.
486. יסורי אהבה — Afflictions of love.
487. יסורין ממרקין — Sufferings purify.
488. יסורין של אהבה — Afflictions of love.
489. יצרא דעבירה דאתלבן כתלגא חיוורא — Evil inclination that has been whitened like snow.
490. ירח מנחה מנוחה — Offers a pleasing sacrifice of rest.
491. ירכין עילאין — Supernal thighs.
492. יְשִׁיבָה הָעֶלְיוֹנָה — Supernal academy.
493. ישוב אל יי — Return to the LORD.
494. ישר הפוך ישר — Forward, reverse, forward.
495. ישראל זוטא — Lesser Israel.
496. יתקלס עילאה — The Most High will be praised.
497. י״ג מדות הרחמים — Thirteen Attributes of Mercy.
498. כְּבַלַּע — Being swallowed up/covered.
499. כִּסֵּא דִּין — Throne of judgment.
500. כִּסֵּא רַחֲמִים — Throne of mercy.
501. כַּפָּרָה — Atonement.
502. כָּרְסַיֵּהּ שְׁבִיבִין דִּי נוּר — His throne was fiery flames.
503. כָּרֵת — Spiritual excision.
504. כֹּפֶר — Ransom.

505. כּוֹס־יְשׁוּעוֹת — Cup of salvation.
506. כגירא בעיניה דשטנא — Like an arrow in Satan's eye (idiom for unnecessarily provoking evil forces).
507. כד אחשכת נהורא ואתדבקת בחויא — When the light darkens and cleaves to the serpent.
508. כוונה נאותה — Appropriate intention/kavvanah.
509. כוונות היחודים — Unification intentions.
510. כוונות עליונות — Higher intentions (kavvanot; mystical meditations).
511. כוונת הזווג — Intention for marital union.
512. כוונת היחוד — Intention of unification.
513. כוונתם — Their spiritual intentions/kavvanot.
514. כוז"ו במוכס"ז כוז"ו — KuZu BeMuKhSaZ KuZu (letter substitution of the Tetragrammaton).
515. כוין/לכוין — To focus, to direct one's intention (kavvanah).
516. כורסיה שביבין דנור — His throne of fiery flames.
517. כורסיין — Thrones.
518. כח הדין — Power of judgment.
519. כח החצונים — Power of the external forces.
520. כח הטומאה שלצד צפון — Power of impurity from the northern side.
521. כח הימין — Power of the right (associated with mercy and kindness in Kabbalah).
522. כח הצפוני — Power of the northern one.
523. כח חצוני — External force/power.
524. כחות הדינים — Forces of judgment.
525. כחות החיצונים — External forces (negative spiritual entities).
526. כחות החסדים — Forces of loving-kindness.
527. כחות החצונים — External forces (negative spiritual entities).
528. כחות הקטגוריא — Accusatory forces/powers of prosecution.
529. כחות משפיעים — Forces that bestow.
530. כחות קדושים מקבלים — Holy forces that receive.
531. כחות שנתלבשו בדין — Forces clothed in judgment.
532. כליותי — My kidneys (metaphorically: innermost thoughts and feelings).
533. כללות החסד שבמלכות אצילות — Totality of Chesed within Malkhut of Atzilut.
534. כמסוס נוסס — Like a melting standard (a banner or flag dissolving).
535. כמשחל ביניתא מחלבא — Like drawing a fish from milk.
536. כנסת ישראל — Congregation of Israel.
537. כנפי מצוה — Wings of a commandment.
538. כסאסא ליה לשבולתא — Like chaff adorns grain.
539. כעתר — Like a pitchfork (which turns things over, metaphor for transformative prayer).
540. כף הקלע — Hollow of a sling (form of spiritual punishment).
541. כפרת נפשו — Atonement of his soul.
542. כרוזא קרי ופס ידא כתבא — The herald proclaims and the writing hand writes.
543. כשאור שבעסה — As the leaven in the dough.
544. כתנות אור — Garments of light.
545. כתנות עור — Garments of skin (representing physical limitation).
546. כתר הרחמים — Crown of Mercy (highest divine attribute).
547. כתרי מלכא — Crowns of the King.

548. ל״ב נתיבות חכמה העליונה — Thirty-two paths of supernal wisdom.

549. לְהִשְׁתַּטֵּחַ — To prostrate oneself (specifically at a grave, a practice of visiting and praying at the graves of the righteous).

550. לְמַדְחֵפֹּת — To overthrow him.

551. לִפְדוּתְךָ סָבָרִית — For Your redemption I hope.

552. לִקְנֵי הַיָּמִין — At the end of the right hand.

553. לְתַקֵּן עוֹלָם בְּמַלְכוּת שַׁדַּי — To perfect the world under the kingdom of the Almighty.

554. לִוְיָתָן — Leviathan.

555. לִפְנִים מִשּׁוּרַת הַדִּין — Beyond the strict measure of judgment.

556. לִשְׁאוֹל — To Sheol (the grave/netherworld).

557. לַאו הַנִּתָּק לַעֲשֵׂה — Negative commandment remedied by a positive action.

558. לַעֲנָה וְרֹאשׁ — Wormwood and gall (bitter substances symbolizing suffering).

559. לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא — The World to Come.

560. לֹבֶן הָעֶלְיוֹן — Supernal Whiteness.

561. לט — Ladanum (aromatic resin).

562. לאתפוסי אדרא — To be a representative of the community.

563. לב נשבר ונדכה — Broken and contrite heart.

564. לבוש נשמתו — Garment of his soul.

565. לבוש עור הנחש — Garment of the serpent's skin.

566. לבושי הנשמות — Garments of souls.

567. לבושים ראשונים ושניים — First and second garments.

568. לבנון — Lebanon.

569. לברזיליה — To her mighty one (referring to Barzillai from the Bible).

570. להט החרב המתהפכת — Flame of the revolving sword.

571. להכניע החצוני — To subdue the external forces.

572. להפריח רוחות — To drive away spirits.

573. לובן העליון — Supernal whiteness.

574. לוז — Luz.

575. לזכות בהם את הרבים — To bring merit to the many.

576. ליחדא קב״ה עם שכינתיה — To unify the Holy One, blessed be He, with His Divine Presence.

577. ליל החותם — Night of sealing.

578. למנצח בנגינותי — To the Chief Musician with my stringed instruments.

579. למען יופיע עליו מהודו — So that His splendor may shine upon him.

580. למתק כחות הדין — To sweeten the forces of judgment.

581. לעורר הזווג — To awaken the union.

582. לעת מצוא — At a favorable time.

583. לצד עלאה — Toward the supernal side.

584. לקשר מדת לילה ביום — To connect the attribute of night with day.

585. לשם יחוד ה׳ — For the sake of divine unification.

586. מ״ב שמהן — 42 divine names.

587. מ״ט מדרגות הטומאה — Forty-nine levels of impurity.

588. מ״ט שערי בינה — 49 gates of Understanding.

589. מ״ט שערי טהרה — Forty-nine gates of purity.

590. מְנַחֵם — Comforter.

591. מְעוֹן קָדְשֶׁךָ — Your holy dwelling place.
592. מְקוֹר חַיִּים — Fountain of life.
593. מְשִׁיחוֹ — His anointed one.
594. מְשׁוּבָתִי — My backsliding/apostasy.
595. מְתִיבָתֵי עִלָּאֵי — Supernal academies.
596. מְתִיבָתָא דִּרְקִיעָא — Heavenly academy.
597. מְתִיבוֹת — Heavenly academies.
598. מִגְדְּלוֹת מֻרְקָחִים — Towers of perfumes/aromatic preparations.
599. מִטָּתוֹ שֶׁלִּשְׁלֹמֹה — Solomon's bed.
600. מִימִינוֹ מִיכָאֵל מִשְּׂמֹאלוֹ וְגַבְרִיאֵל מִלְּפָנָיו רְפָאֵל מֵאֲחוֹרָיו נוֹרִיאֵל וְעַל רֹאשׁוֹ שְׁכִינַת אֵל — Michael on his right, Gabriel on his left, Raphael before him, Noriel behind him, and the Divine Presence above his head.
601. מִכְתָּם — Miktam.
602. מִמְּתֵי מֶחֱלָד — From men of the world/age.
603. מִפַּחַד בַּלֵּילוֹת — Because of fear in the nights.
604. מִצְחָא עִלָּאָה — Supernal Forehead.
605. מַזָּלִי — My fortune/destiny.
606. מַלְאֲכֵי חֶסֶד — Angels of loving-kindness.
607. מַלְאֲכֵי חֶסֶד — Angels of loving-kindness.
608. מַלְאֲכֵי רַחֲמִים — Angels of mercy.
609. מַלְכִּי צֶדֶק — Melchizedek.
610. מַעֲלָם — Their unfaithfulness/trespass.
611. מַעְיְנֵי הַיְשׁוּעָה — Wells of salvation.
612. מַצְדִּיקֵי הָרַבִּים — Those who turn many to righteousness.
613. מַרְפֵּא בִּכְנָפֶיהָ — Healing in His wings.
614. מַשְׂכִּיל — Maskil.
615. מָארֵי מְתִיבָתָן — Masters of the academies (heavenly yeshivot).
616. מָעוֹג — Mocking feast, mockery.
617. מָרוֹם — From on high.
618. מֹטוֹת עֻלָּם — Bars of their yoke (the wooden crosspieces of an animal's yoke).
619. מאור המלכות — Light of Malkhut (Kingdom).
620. מאורי אור — Luminaries of light.
621. מאורי האש — Luminaries of fire.
622. מאן דתקיף ליה עלמא טובא — One whom the world greatly oppresses.
623. מארי דברית — Masters of the covenant.
624. מארי דיבבא — Wailing-masters (masters of wailing).
625. מארי דיללה — Howling-masters (masters of howling).
626. מארי דצוארי — Masters of the neck.
627. מארי דקלין — Masters of voices.
628. מארי תריסין — Shield-bearers (masters of shields).
629. מאריך אנפין — Arich Anpin (Long Face).
630. מבסם הנהגת הדין — Sweetening the governance of judgment.
631. מגו עקו ותבירא דלבא — From distress and brokenness of heart.
632. מגלגלים חובה על ידי חייב — Brings about guilt through the guilty.

633. מדא ועטופא דמצוה ודקדושה — Garment and wrapping of commandment and holiness.
634. מדה״ד הקשה — Harsh judgment (the severe aspect of divine judgment).
635. מדה״ד הרפה — Mild judgment (the lenient aspect of divine judgment).
636. מדורות שבגיהנם — Chambers of Gehenna.
637. מדורי העשיה — Dwelling places of Asiyah (Action).
638. מדורין בסוד העשיה רוחניותי — Dwellings of the spiritual realm of Asiyah.
639. מדות העליונות — Supernal attributes.
640. מדרש הנעלם — Midrash HaNe'elam (Hidden Midrash).
641. מדת הוד — Attribute of Hod.
642. מדת החסד — Attribute of Loving-kindness.
643. מדת המלכות — Attribute of Malkhut.
644. מדת הרחמים — Attribute of mercy.
645. מהלאל — Mahalalel.
646. מוֹפֵת — Wonder, portent, sign.
647. מוֹרֶה — Early rain.
648. מוּסַר שְׁלוֹמֵנוּ — Chastisement for our peace.
649. מוחא סתימא — Mocha Stima (Concealed Brain).
650. מוחין דלגאו — Inner minds/consciousness.
651. מוצא נשמה רוח ונפש — Origin of neshamah, ruach, and nefesh.
652. מותנא תניינא — Secondary death.
653. מזבח העליון — Supernal altar.
654. מזהרא עילאה — Supernal radiance (divine light that clothes purified souls).
655. מזלא עילאה — Supernal mazal (celestial influence).
656. מזלו של אדם — A person's mazal (spiritual destiny/fortune).
657. מזליה שברקיע — Celestial guardian angel/spiritual source in the firmament.
658. מחבלא דנבל שמיה — The destroyer whose name is Naval (vile).
659. מחוי במחוג — Makes indications with a compass.
660. מחזור המאור הקטן — Cycle of the lesser luminary (monthly cycle of the moon).
661. מחיצתו — His partition (in the afterlife).
662. מחנות ומרכבות עליונות — Celestial camps and chariots.
663. מחצד״י חקל״א קדישא — Reapers of the holy field.
664. מחצדי חקלא עילאה — Reapers of the supernal field.
665. מטטרו״ן שר הפנים — Metatron, Prince of the Presence.
666. מטטרון שר הפנים — Metatron, Prince of the Divine Presence.
667. מטל חלקו — The dew of his portion.
668. מיין דכורין — Masculine waters.
669. מיין נוקבין — Feminine waters.
670. מילוי שם הוי״ה באלפין — Expanded divine name YHVH spelled with alephs.
671. מיעוט הירח — Diminishment of the moon.
672. מירוק הזוהמא — Purification of spiritual defilement.
673. מיתוק הדינים — Sweetening of judgments.
674. מיתוק לדינין — Sweetening of judgments.
675. מיתת נשיקה — Death by divine kiss.
676. מיתתה על פי ה׳ — Death by the mouth of the Lord.

677. מכון הר ציון — Foundation of Mount Zion.
678. מכח החצוני — From external forces.
679. מלאך מזלו — Guardian angel.
680. מלאכי חבלה — Angels of destruction.
681. מלה — Word (referring to the Divine Feminine/Malkhut).
682. מלכא סבא — Ancient King.
683. מלכות אדנ״י — Malkhut/Adnut (Kingdom, the lowest divine sefirah associated with the divine name Adonai).
684. מלכות אם כל הנשמות — Malkhut, mother of all souls.
685. מלכות ש״ן ב״ת — Malkhut which is Shin Bat (Kingdom as Daughter).
686. מלכות שמים — Kingdom of Heaven (Malkhut).
687. מלכות ת״ת בינה — Malkhut, Tiferet, and Binah (three divine sefirot/emanations).
688. ממונה דקאים לסטר דרום — The appointed angel who stands to the south.
689. ממצדיקי הרבים — Those who bring merit to the many.
690. מנהג ותיקין — Custom of the pious elders (a category of custom with special halakhic weight).
691. מנהרי אפרסמונא דכיא — Rivers of pure balsam oil.
692. מנוחה לעצם של התחיה — Rest for the bone of resurrection.
693. מנוחות שאננות — Tranquil resting places.
694. מניה וביה אבא ליזיל ביה נרגא — From itself comes the ax handle [to fell the tree].
695. מנעימותא עילאה — Supernal pleasantness.
696. מס׳ שמחות — Masechet Semachot.
697. מסטין — Prosecutor/accuser.
698. מסטרא דנוקבא — From the feminine aspect (associated with judgment in Kabbalah).
699. מסטרא דשמאלא — From the left side (the side of judgment in Kabbalistic thought).
700. מסיומא דגופא — Conclusion of the body.
701. מסכת שמחות — Tractate Semachot (a rabbinic text on mourning practices).
702. מעבר י״בק — Crossing of the Yabok.
703. מעבר יבק — Crossing of the Yabok.
704. מעבר יב״ק — Crossing of the Jabbok.
705. מעילה — Misappropriation of sacred property.
706. מעילות — Misappropriation of sacred property.
707. מעירי שחר — Illuminators of Dawn.
708. מעכב עבידתא דקב״ה מלמעבד — Impedes the work of the Holy One, blessed be He, from being accomplished.
709. מעלמא דאתגליא — From the revealed world.
710. מעלמא דאתכסיא — From the concealed world.
711. מעלמא דנוקבא — From the feminine realm.
712. מעמד ומושב — Standing and sitting ceremony.
713. מעמדות ומושבות — Standings and sittings (ceremonial practices during mourning).
714. מעשה מרכבה — Work of the Chariot (esoteric mystical studies based on Ezekiel's vision).
715. מפי גבורה — From the mouth of Power (divine source).
716. מצח הרצון — Forehead of Will (kabbalistic reference to divine intention).
717. מקדש י״ה — Sanctuary of Yah (referring to the biblical canon).
718. מקום — Place.

719. מקור מעין העליון — Source of the supernal spring.
720. מקטרגים — Accusers (spiritual prosecutors who bring attention to a person's sins).
721. מקצין בנטיעות — Cutting the plantings (severing divine unity).
722. מראות נגעים — Appearances of afflictions.
723. מרבות — Aravot (the highest of the seven heavens).
724. מרהב — Rahab.
725. מרכבה ליצר הרע — Vehicle for the evil inclination.
726. מרכבה למלוים עליונים — Vehicle for the supernal escorts (mystical concept where humans below mirror and channel heavenly forces).
727. מרכבה לשכינה — Chariot for the Divine Presence.
728. מרכבה מרקדה — Dancing chariot (mystical reference to divine manifestation).
729. מרכבותיה — Its chariots (vehicles for divine influence).
730. מרכבת האבות — The chariot of the Patriarchs.
731. מרשו״ת לרשו״ת — From domain to domain.
732. משיח בן דוד — Messiah son of David.
733. משיח בן יוסף — Messiah son of Joseph.
734. משיחת״א קדישא דאורייתא — Holy anointing of the Torah.
735. משכיות האורה — Chambers of light.
736. משלחת מלאכי רעים — Company of evil angels.
737. משם של מ״ב — From the 42-letter Name.
738. מת מצוה — Unattended corpse that requires immediate burial.
739. מתחרה עם יצרו — Contends with his evil inclination.
740. מתיבתא דיליה לקבל מתיבתא עילאה — His academy corresponds to the supernal academy.
741. מתיבתא דרקיעא — Heavenly academy.
742. מתיבתאן עילאין — Heavenly academies.
743. מתמתקים כחות הדין — The forces of judgment are sweetened.
744. נְהַר דִּי נוּר — River of fire.
745. נְכֹאת — Gum (aromatic substance).
746. נְפוּגוֹתַי — I am numb, benumbed, grown cold.
747. נְשִׁיקָה — Divine kiss.
748. נְשָׁמָה — Neshamah (highest level of soul).
749. נְשָׁמוֹת שֶׁנִּתְאַחֲדוּ — Souls that have united.
750. נִבְזֶה בְּעֵינָיו נִמְאָס — In whose eyes a contemptible person is despised.
751. נִשְׁבַּע לְהָרַע וְלֹא יָמֵר — Swears to his own detriment and does not change.
752. נִשְׁמָתִי — My neshamah (higher soul).
753. נִשְׁמָתוֹ — His neshamah (higher soul).
754. נָכִים — Attackers, smiters.
755. נַחֲלֵי דְאֲפַרְסְמוֹנָא דַכְיָא — Rivers of pure balsam oil.
756. נַחֲלַת גּוֹיִם — Inheritance of the nations.
757. נַחַל עֲדָנָיו — Stream of His delights.
758. נַפְשֵׁנוּ כְּצִפּוֹר נִמְלְטָה — Our soul has escaped like a bird.
759. נַפְשׁוֹ — His nefesh (vital soul).
760. נָטָף וּשְׁחֵלֶת וְחֶלְבְּנָה — Stacte, onycha, and galbanum.
761. נֹגְשֶׂיךָ — Your taskmasters.

762. נִפְּשׁ עֲלִיָּתוֹ — Breath of his ascension.
763. נאצלות — Emanate.
764. נביעו דדכורא — Masculine flow.
765. נגידי התלי — Rulers of the Dragon's Head.
766. נהירו דעתיקא — Light of the Ancient One.
767. נהר דינור — River of Fire.
768. נהרי דאפרסמונא דכיא — Rivers of pure balsam oil.
769. נוֹעַם יְדִידוּתֶיךָ — Pleasantness of Your beloved presence.
770. נובלות חכמה — Fallen fruit of wisdom.
771. נובלת החכמה — Fallen fruit of wisdom.
772. נובלת חכמה של מעלה — Fallen fruit of supernal wisdom.
773. נוה אפריון — Pavilion of royalty.
774. נוקבא דתהומא רבה — Great abyss (where negative forces are banished).
775. נוקביה דזעיר — Feminine aspect of Zeir Anpin.
776. נותר — Notar.
777. נחל עדניך — River of Your delights.
778. נחלה בלא מצרים — Inheritance without boundaries.
779. נחש עקלתון — Twisted serpent (a reference to the primordial serpent).
780. ניצוץ השכינה — Spark of the Divine Presence.
781. ניצוצות נשמת — Soul-sparks (mystical concept of divine soul fragments).
782. נעוץ סופם בתחלתם — Their end is wedged in their beginning.
783. נפילת אפים — Nefilat Apayim (falling on one's face).
784. נפש הבהמית — Animal soul.
785. נפש החיונית — Vital life-force.
786. נפש המרגשת — Sensing nefesh.
787. נפש העולם — World-Soul.
788. נפש יתירה — Additional soul.
789. נפש רוח ונשמה — Soul, spirit, and higher soul (the three levels of the soul in Kabbalah).
790. נפש רוח נשמה חיה יחידה — The five levels of the soul (Nefesh, Ruach, Neshamah, Chayah, Yechidah).
791. נפשא ורוחא ונשמתא — Nefesh, ruach, and neshamah.
792. נפשה — Nefesh (vital soul, the lowest level of the soul).
793. נפשו רוחו ונשמתו — His soul, spirit, and higher soul (the three primary levels of the soul in Kabbalah).
794. נפשי — My nefesh (vital soul).
795. נצוץ נשמת — Spark of the soul.
796. נצוצות הקדושה — Sparks of holiness.
797. נצוצות נשמותם — Sparks of their souls.
798. נצוצי נשמותיהם — Sparks of their souls.
799. נצח הוד יסוד — Netzach, Hod, and Yesod (Victory, Splendor, and Foundation).
800. נקודה סתומה — Hidden point.
801. נקודה תחתונה — Lower point.
802. נקודת ציון — Point of Zion.
803. נרתק של קדושה — Vessel of holiness.

804. נרתקן — Their sheath/vessel.
805. נשיבו רוחא דחיי — Breathing of the spirit of life.
806. נשיקות — Kisses (mystical union of spirits).
807. נשיקין דרוחא ברוחא — Kisses of spirit with spirit.
808. נשך ותרבית — Interest and excessive profit.
809. נשמה יתירה — Additional soul (received on Sabbaths and festivals).
810. נשמה ממושכנת — Pledged soul (referring to the soul's reluctant descent into the physical world).
811. נשמה רוח נפש — Neshamah, ruach, nefesh (the three components of the soul).
812. נשמות ישראל ממחצב א׳ — Souls of Israel from one source.
813. נשמות יתרות — Additional souls.
814. נשמת האצילות — Nishmat ha-Atzilut (Soul of Emanation).
815. נשמתא לנשמתא — Soul of the soul.
816. נשמתו ורוחו ונפשו — His neshamah, ruach, and nefesh (soul components).
817. נשמתו של עולם — Soul of the World.
818. נשמתי — My neshamah (highest level of soul).
819. ס״מ ולילית — Samael and Lilith (names of negative spiritual entities in Jewish mysticism).
820. סְפִירָן — Sefirot (divine emanations).
821. סִטְרָא אָחֳרָא — The Other Side.
822. סֶלָה — Selah.
823. סדר המעמדות — Order of Ma'amadot.
824. סדר הקומה השלימה — Order of the complete divine structure.
825. סוֹד יְיָ — The secret counsel of the LORD.
826. סוד הנר — The mystery of the lamp.
827. סוד העפר — Mystery of earth.
828. סוד הקטלנית — Secret of the 'killer wife'.
829. סוד השערות — Mystery of the hairs.
830. סוד נקודה האמצעית — The secret of the central point.
831. סוכת דוד הנופלת — The fallen booth of David.
832. סטר גבורה — Side of Gevurah (the divine attribute of Strength/Judgment in Kabbalah).
833. סטרא אחרא — Sitra Achra (the Other Side).
834. סטרא בישא — Evil side.
835. סטרא דמסאבא — Side of impurity.
836. סטרא דמסאבותא — Side of impurity.
837. סלה — Selah (musical direction or pause for reflection).
838. סמאל — Samael (angelic figure associated with accusation and death).
839. סנדלפון — Sandalfon.
840. סעודי דמהימנותא קדישא — Meals of holy faith.
841. ספיחי ספיחים — Aftergrowths of aftergrowths.
842. ספירה — Divine emanation.
843. ספירות הבנין — Sefirot of construction.
844. ספירות העליונות — Higher sefirot (divine emanations).
845. ספר יצירה — Sefer Yetzirah (Book of Formation).
846. ספר פרדס — Sefer Pardes (Book of Pardes).

847. ספרא דצניעותא — Safra D'Tzniuta (Book of Concealment).
848. סתימא דכל סתימין — Most Hidden of all Hidden Ones.
849. סתרי תורה — Secrets of Torah (mystical teachings).
850. ס״מ — Samael.
851. ע״א ג״ע וש״ד — Idolatry, forbidden sexual relations, and bloodshed.
852. ע״ב גשרי החסד — Seventy-two bridges of kindness.
853. ע״ב שמות — 72 divine names.
854. ע״דן נ״הר ג״ן — Eden, River, Garden (kabbalistic reference to spiritual dimensions of Sabbath meals).
855. עֲמִידָתָם — Their rising/resurrection.
856. עֲרָבוֹת — Aravot.
857. עִמְקֵי סוֹדֶךָ — The depths of Your mysteries.
858. עֵמֶק הַבָּכָא — Valley of Baca.
859. עַיִן טוֹבָה — Good eye.
860. עַל מוּת — Unto death.
861. עַלְמִין דְּחֶבסוּפָא וְרָצוֹן — Worlds of longing and favor.
862. עַשְׁתְּרֹת צֹאנֶךָ — Offspring of your flock.
863. עַתִּיק יוֹמִין — Ancient of Days.
864. עַתִּיקָא קַדִּישָׁא — Holy Ancient One.
865. עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ — My strength and song is the LORD.
866. עָרַב — Be a guarantor/surety.
867. עָשְׁשָׁה בְכַעַס עֵינִי — My eye is wasted from grief.
868. עָזִּי וְזִמְרָת יָהּ — My strength and song is the LORD.
869. עבירה לשמה — A transgression for the sake of Heaven.
870. עגלה ערופה — Heifer whose neck is broken.
871. עדן ועדנה — Eden and Ednah.
872. עדן עילאה — Eden Ila'ah (Upper Eden).
873. עדן תתאה — Eden Tata'ah (Lower Eden).
874. עובדא דינוקא — Story of the child (a narrative in the Zohar).
875. עולם האופנים — World of the Ophanim (Wheels, a category of angels).
876. עולם האצילות — World of Atzilut/Emanation (the highest of four kabbalistic worlds).
877. עולם הבריאה — World of Creation.
878. עולם הזכר — Olam ha-Zachar (Masculine World).
879. עולם היצירה — World of Yetzirah/Formation (the second-lowest of four kabbalistic worlds).
880. עולם הכסא — World of the Throne (Beriah, the third of four kabbalistic worlds).
881. עולם הנקבה — Olam ha-Nekevah (Feminine World).
882. עולם הנקביי — Feminine world.
883. עולם הנקודות — World of Points.
884. עולם הנשמות — World of Souls.
885. עולם העשיה — World of Action (Asiyah).
886. עולם השכל — World of intellect (the spiritual realm after death).
887. עולם התהו׳ — World of Chaos.
888. עולם התמורה והכליון — World of exchange and destruction.
889. עולם שכלו שבת — A world that is entirely Sabbath.

890. עולמות — Worlds.
891. עולמתא שפירתא דלית לה עיינין — A beautiful maiden without eyes.
892. עוף בלתי טהור — Impure bird (metaphor for harmful spiritual forces).
893. עטרין — Crowns (divine emanations).
894. עילאי ותתאי — Upper and lower realms.
895. עילת העילות — Cause of all causes.
896. עין יצרו — Eye of his inclination.
897. עינא אחרא דפגעא — Harmful "evil eye".
898. עינא פקיחא — Watchful Eye (a kabbalistic term for divine providence).
899. עינין דמתלהטן — Flaming Eyes (a kabbalistic reference to divine judgment).
900. עיר וקדיש — City and holy one.
901. עכנא דמערתא — Snake of the cave.
902. עלמא דדכורא — Masculine realm.
903. עלמא סתימא — Concealed realm.
904. עלמין דכסופא — Worlds of divine delight.
905. עלת העלות — Cause of all Causes (a kabbalistic term for God).
906. עמוד האמצעי — Central pillar.
907. עמודא דאמציעתא — Central column.
908. עמודא דאמצעיתא — Central column (the middle sefirot in the kabbalistic tree, especially Tiferet).
909. עמודא דנורא — Amuda D'Nura (Pillar of Fire).
910. עמודים סמכין דעלמא — Pillars supporting the world.
911. עץ הדעת טוב ורע — Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil.
912. עצבונ״א דבשר״א — Distress of the flesh.
913. עצבונא דבישרא — Sadness/pain of the flesh.
914. עצבונא דבשרא — Distress of the flesh.
915. ערי הרכב — Cities of the chariots (metaphor for celestial realms).
916. ערקתא דמסאנא — Strap of the sandal (reference to the chalitzah ritual of transferring rights).
917. עש״ן תג״ל — Smoke shall rejoice.
918. עשייה רוחניות — Spiritual realm of Asiyah (the lowest of four kabbalistic worlds).
919. עשר כתרין תתאין — Ten lower crowns.
920. עשר נצוצות — Ten sparks.
921. עשר ספירות — Ten sefirot.
922. עשר ספירן — Ten sefirot (divine emanations).
923. עשרה שליטים העליונים — Ten supernal rulers.
924. עתיק יומיא — Ancient of Days.
925. עתיקא דעתיקין — Ancient of Ancients (divine configuration).
926. עתיקא קדישא — Holy Ancient One.
927. עתר ענן הקטרת — Cloud of Incense Prayer.
928. פְּלֵטַת גּוֹלַת אֲרִיאֵל — Remnant of the exiled Ariel.
929. פְּקֻדָּתֵךְ — Your overseers.
930. פֶּן־אִישַׁן הַמָּוֶת — Lest I sleep the sleep of death.
931. פַּמִּילְיָאי עִלָּאי — Heavenly/upper hosts.
932. פַּמִּילְיָאי תַּתָּאי — Earthly/lower hosts.

933. פָּדִיתָ אוֹתִי יְיָ אֵל אֱמֶת — You have redeemed me, O LORD, God of truth.
934. פגול — Pigul.
935. פורענות המת — Punishment of the dead.
936. פחד יצחק — Pachad Yitzchak (Fear of Isaac, a kabbalistic reference to the divine attribute of Gevurah/Judgment).
937. פטום הקטרת — Preparation of the Incense.
938. פליטת הגלגל — Escape of the wheel.
939. פלפול — Sharp discourse/dialectical reasoning.
940. פמליא של מעלה — Heavenly host/celestial retinue.
941. פן אדם שבמרכבה — Human face of the divine chariot.
942. פני אריה — Face of the lion.
943. פני מטרונה — Face of the Matronita (Divine Feminine).
944. פנים המנהגים — Governing faces.
945. פנימיות הספירות — Inner aspects of the Sefirot.
946. פסוקי היחוד — Verses of unification.
947. פקדונא דמריה — Deposit from her Master.
948. פקח — Open (with kabbalistic numerical significance).
949. פרגוד — The heavenly curtain (separating divine realms).
950. פרונקא דמלאכא דמותא — Messenger of the Angel of Death.
951. פרקי היכלות — Chapters of the Heavenly Palaces (mystical text).
952. פשיטת הלבוש החומר — Removal of the material garment (metaphor for death).
953. פשעים — Transgressions.
954. צְבָאִי — My appointed time/service.
955. צְרוֹר הַחַיִּים — The bond of life.
956. צדוק הַדִּין — Justification of Divine Judgment.
957. צִיִּים — Desert dwellers.
958. צַחְצָחוֹת — Clear radiance (a term from Isaiah 58:11 referring to divine satisfaction).
959. צד״ק וצדק״ה — Tzedek and Tzedakah (divine aspects of justice and charity).
960. צדוק הדין — Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment).
961. צדיק וצדק — Righteous One and Righteousness (Yesod and Malkhut in Kabbalah).
962. צדיק חי עלמא — Righteous One, Life of the World.
963. צדיק חי עלמין — The Righteous One, Life of the Worlds (the sefirah of Yesod).
964. צדיק יסוד עולם — The righteous person, foundation of the world (a reference to the sefirah of Yesod).
965. צדיק עילאה — Supernal Righteous One.
966. צדק אימא תתאה — Tzedek, the lower Mother.
967. צדק ושלום — Righteousness and peace.
968. צוּר מָעוֹן — Rock of habitation.
969. צואה רותחת — Boiling excrement (a metaphorical description of a level in Gehenna).
970. צוותה על המתים — Commandment regarding the dead.
971. צחצחות — Spiritual radiances.
972. צידוק הדין — Tzidduk HaDin (Justification of Divine Judgment).
973. צינורות הקדושה — Channels of holiness.
974. ציפרא קדישא — Holy bird.

975. ציקי קדירה — Residue of the pot.
976. צירופי אלהים — Permutations of Elohim.
977. צלם העליון — Supernal image/divine image.
978. צלם של מעלה — Supernal image (divine form in which humans are created).
979. צלם תחתון — Lower image.
980. צלמות — Tzalmavet (shadow of death).
981. צנור הנעלם — Hidden channel (mystical pathway between divine emanations).
982. צנורות ההשפעה — Channels of divine influence.
983. צנורות עליונות — Supernal channels.
984. צנורות של מעלה — Supernal channels.
985. צפרין דמקננן — Nesting birds.
986. צרופי הוי״ה — Permutations of the Divine Name YHVH.
987. צרופים — Tzerufim (letter combinations).
988. צרור החיים — Bond of life.
989. צרור עליון — Supernal bond (the highest level where souls are bound to divine life).
990. צרורא דחיי — Bond of Life.
991. צרעת — Leprosy (metaphorically representing spiritual impurity).
992. קְטֹרֶת הַסַּמִּים — Incense of spices.
993. קְטוֹרֶת — Incense.
994. קְטֹרֶת הַסַּמִּים — Aromatic incense.
995. קֵץ הַחַיִּים — End of days.
996. קֶטֶב יָשׁוּד צָהֳרָיִם — Destruction that ravages at noon.
997. קֶרִי — Chance/happenstance.
998. קֶרֶן יִשְׁעִי — Horn of my salvation.
999. קָרְבָּן עוֹלָה וְיוֹרֵד — Sliding-scale offering.
1000. קבר התהום — Grave of the abyss.
1001. קבר עליון — Celestial grave.
1002. קדמונו של עולם — The Ancient One of the world.
1003. קו האמצעי — Middle pillar.
1004. קו השוה — Alignment of cosmic forces.
1005. קומת הקדושה — Divine structure.
1006. קוצו של יו״ד — Point of the Yod (smallest element of the divine name).
1007. קושט הכלה — Adorning the bride.
1008. קטגורא — Accusation/prosecution (in the heavenly court).
1009. קטרוג החצונים — Accusations of the external forces.
1010. קליפה הנקרא נגה — Kelipah called Nogah.
1011. קליפין — Husks/shells (negative spiritual forces that conceal divine light).
1012. קליפת החמור — The donkey's shell (negative force).
1013. קליפת נוגה — Kelipat Nogah (translucent shell).
1014. קנין סודר — Kinyan sudar (acquisition through a garment).
1015. קרבן תענית — Sacrifice of Fasting.
1016. קרי כתיב — Keri-ketiv (read but written differently).
1017. קריינא דאגרתא איהו ליהוי פרונקא — The bearer of the letter should be its deliverer.
1018. קרן ופירות — Principal and fruits.

1019. קרקע ערבות — Ground of Aravot (mystical celestial realm).
1020. קשה רימה למת — The worm is painful to the dead.
1021. קשוטי התחתונים — Adornments of those below.
1022. קשוטיה — Its adornments (spiritual embellishments).
1023. קשוטים — Kishutim (spiritual adornments).
1024. ר״מ פרשת בהר סיני — Ra'aya Mehemna, Parashat Behar Sinai.
1025. רְפָאִים — Shades/spirits of the dead.
1026. רֵאשִׁית חָכְמָה יִרְאַת יְיָ — The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom.
1027. רֵיחַ נִיחוֹחַ — Pleasing fragrance.
1028. רַמ״ח אֵבָרִים וְשַׁסַ״ה גִּידִים — 248 limbs and 365 sinews.
1029. רְקַמְתָּנִי — I was woven together.
1030. ראשי המשחית — Heads of the destroyer.
1031. רבנן סבוראי — Rabbanan Savorai (post-Talmudic sages).
1032. רוּחוֹ — His ruach (spirit).
1033. רוח הטומאה מצד הנחש — The spirit of impurity from the serpent.
1034. רוח משפט — Spirit of judgment.
1035. רוח נשברה — Broken spirit.
1036. רוח פסקונית — Decisive spirit.
1037. רוחא דמסאבא — Spirit of impurity.
1038. רוחו של עולם — World-Spirit.
1039. רוחות פורחות — Flying spirits (a category of harmful spiritual entities).
1040. רוחי — My ruach (spirit, middle level of soul).
1041. רוכב ערבות — Rider of Aravot (highest heaven).
1042. רומחי הגבורה — Spears of Gevurah (Strength/Judgment).
1043. רזי התורה הקדומה — Mysteries of the primordial Torah.
1044. רזין דאורייתא — Secrets of the Torah.
1045. רחובות הנהר — The expanses of the river.
1046. רחיצה הגדולה — The great washing ritual.
1047. רחל — Rachel (representing the lower aspect of the Divine Feminine).
1048. ריעין ודודין — Companions and lovers.
1049. רישא איוורא — White Head.
1050. רישא דא״א — Reisha d'Arich Anpin (Head of the Long Face).
1051. רישא חיוורא — White Head.
1052. רישא עילאה חיוורא — Reisha Ila'ah Chivra (Supernal White Head).
1053. ריתחא — Divine anger/time of judgment.
1054. רל״א שערים — 231 gates.
1055. רמ״ח אברי הקומה העליונה — 248 limbs of the supernal structure.
1056. רמ״ח כחות זכרים ברמ״ח נקבות — 248 masculine powers with 248 feminine powers.
1057. רעוא עילאה — Supreme will.
1058. רעוא עלאה — Supernal will.
1059. רעותא דלבא — Desire/will of the heart.
1060. רעותא עילאה — Supernal will.
1061. רעותין — Desires (divine will-forces).
1062. רעיא מהימנא — Ra'aya Mehemna (The Faithful Shepherd, a section of the Zohar).

1063. רעיה תמה — Perfect shepherd (feminine).
1064. רעים דלא מתפרשן לעלמין — Friends who never separate.
1065. רצוא ושוב — Running and returning (mystical concept of spiritual oscillation).
1066. רקיע ערבות העליון — Firmament of the supernal Aravot.
1067. רתיכא עילאה קדישא — Holy supernal chariot.
1068. שְׁאוֹר שֶׁבָּעִיסָה — Leaven in the dough.
1069. שְׁגַר אֶלָּפֶיךָ — Increase of your cattle.
1070. שְׁכִינָתֶךָ — Your Divine Presence.
1071. שְׁלֹשׁ עֶשְׂרֵה מִדּוֹתֶיךָ — Your Thirteen Attributes [of Mercy].
1072. שְׂרָפִים — Seraphim.
1073. שִׁיר שֶׁל פְּגָעִים — Song of Afflictions/Demons.
1074. שֶׁבַע כִּתּוֹת שֶׁל צַדִּיקִים וַחֲסִידִים — Seven classes of righteous and pious ones.
1075. שֶׁמֶשׁ צְדָקָה — Sun of Righteousness.
1076. שַׁחַת — The pit.
1077. שַׁלְהֶבֶתְיָה — Divine flame/flame of the LORD.
1078. שַׁעֲרֵי חֶסֶד — Gates of loving-kindness.
1079. שַׁעֲרֵי יְרוּשָׁלַיִם — Gates of Jerusalem.
1080. שַׁעֲרֵי מָוֶת — Gates of death.
1081. שַׂרְעַפַּי — My anxious thoughts.
1082. שַׂרְעַפָּי — My anxious thoughts.
1083. שָׁלוֹם מְנוּחָתִי — My peaceful rest.
1084. שִׂטְנֵי נַפְשִׁי — Adversaries of my soul.
1085. שׁוֹכְנֵי עָפָר — Dwellers in the dust.
1086. שאול — Sheol.
1087. שאור שבעיסה — Leaven in the dough.
1088. שאיבת מוחא לכלא — Death draws everything to itself.
1089. שבולת הזקן — Flowing locks of the beard.
1090. שבילי דנהרדיעה — Pathways of Nehardea.
1091. שבירת כלים — Breaking of the Vessels.
1092. שבע קצוות — Seven extremities.
1093. שבעה הבלים — Seven breaths/emanations.
1094. שבעים שרים — Seventy celestial princes.
1095. שבקית ופטרית — I abandoned and dismissed.
1096. שוברות המזל — Break through astrological destiny.
1097. שודא דמחצדא חקלא — Casting the harvested field.
1098. שולמית — Shulamite (metaphor for the soul).
1099. שומרי הבית — Keepers of the house.
1100. שושבין המיחד — The unifying Attendant.
1101. שושבינא דמטרוניתא — Attendant of the Divine Presence (Matronita).
1102. שחת טמא — Impure destruction.
1103. שיפין — Limbs (both physical and mystical/cosmic).
1104. שיר של מ״ה — Song of MA”H (refers to a divine name with numerical value 45).
1105. שית דרגין — Six levels/gradations.
1106. שיתין פולסי דנורא — Sixty lashes of fire.

1107. שכיבת שוכני קבר — Discourse of those who dwell in the grave.
1108. שכינה דמקננת במטטרו״ן — Divine Presence that nests in Metatron.
1109. שכינה עילאה — Supernal Divine Presence.
1110. שכינת אל — Divine Presence of God.
1111. שכינתא תתאה — Lower Divine Presence.
1112. שכל היולי — Potential intellect.
1113. שכל נאצל — Emanated intellect.
1114. שלוחי הדין — Agents of judgment (spiritual entities that execute divine judgment).
1115. שלש ראשונות — The three highest sefirot.
1116. שם א׳ מז׳ שמות של מ״ב — First of the seven names of the 42-letter divine Name.
1117. שם אדנות — The divine name Adnut.
1118. שם אהיה — The divine name Ehyeh (I Am/I Will Be).
1119. שם ב״ן — Divine Name Ban.
1120. שם ב׳ מז׳ שמות של מ״ב — The second of the seven names of the 42-letter Divine Name.
1121. שם בן ד׳ — The four-letter Name (Tetragrammaton).
1122. שם ד׳ משם מ״ב — The fourth name of the 42-letter Divine Name.
1123. שם ההוי״ה — The Tetragrammaton (the four-letter divine name YHVH).
1124. שם הו״ה אהיה — Divine names YHVH and Ehyeh.
1125. שם הוי״ה מלא ביודין — Divine Name YHVH spelled fully with Yuds.
1126. שם הויה — The divine name YHVH (the Tetragrammaton).
1127. שם מילוי ההי״ן — Divine Name spelled with heis.
1128. שם ע״ב — 72-letter Name.
1129. שמא גרים — The name is causative.
1130. שמיטת הדין — Sabbatical of judgment (cosmic cycle of divine severity).
1131. שני ערלה — Years of orlah (first three years when a tree's fruit is forbidden).
1132. שעור קומה — Divine structure (literally 'measurement of stature').
1133. שעיר המשתלח לעזאזל — Scapegoat sent to Azazel.
1134. שפחה בישא — Evil maidservant.
1135. שפחה חרופה — Betrothed maidservant.
1136. שפע בינה — Influx of Binah (Understanding).
1137. שפתי תורתו דובבות בקברו — The lips of his Torah teachings murmuring in his grave.
1138. שקד — Almond-shaped essence (the luz bone).
1139. שקתות הגוף — Channels of the body.
1140. שר הקבר — Guardian of the grave.
1141. שר השנים — Prince of the Two Faces.
1142. שרי הימים — Angelic princes of the days.
1143. שרפי קדש — Holy seraphim (angelic beings created through righteous deeds).
1144. שרפים והחיות והאופנים — Seraphim, holy beasts, and wheels.
1145. שש קצוות — Six extremities (the six lower divine attributes).
1146. שתי שולחנות — Two tables.
1147. תְּגַלְגַּל מִדּוֹתֶיךָ — Roll forth Your attributes.
1148. תְּהֹמוֹת הָאָרֶץ — Depths of the earth.
1149. תְּהוֹם רֹבֶצֶת — The deep that lies beneath.
1150. תְּהוֹם־אֶל־תְּהוֹם — Deep calls to deep.

1151. תְּשׁוּבָה שְׁלֵמָה — Complete repentance.
1152. תְּפִלַּת חִן פְּלוּלִי — Graceful judicial prayer/prayer offered with grace.
1153. תִּקּוּנֵי דִיקְנָא יְקִירָא עַלְאָה — Aspects of the precious supernal beard.
1154. תְּשְׁתּוֹחָחִי — Are you cast down.
1155. תֶּהֱמִי — Are you disquieted/moan.
1156. תַּחְתִּיּוֹת הָאָרֶץ — Depths of the earth.
1157. תַּנָּאִים וְהָאֲמוֹרָאִים — Tannaim and Amoraim (the rabbinic sages of the Mishnaic and Talmudic periods).
1158. תַּתִּיר צְרוּרָה — Release the bound.
1159. תּוֹרַת הָאָדָם — Instruction/law of humanity.
1160. תבוסת קבר — Burial area.
1161. תּוֹרָה לִשְׁמָהּ — Torah study for its own sake.
1162. תושיה — Substance/wisdom.
1163. תיאובתא דנוקבא לגבי דכורא — Desire of the female for the male (kabbalistic concept of divine unification).
1164. תיבה עליונה — Supernal ark.
1165. תיקון העליונים — Rectification of the upper realms.
1166. תיקלא לא קיימא באשלמותא — The scale is not perfectly balanced.
1167. תכשיטין דכלה — Bride's ornaments.
1168. תלייה לשם עם הנשמה — Connection between the name and the soul.
1169. תלת סטרין יסודי עלמא — Three aspects of the world's elements.
1170. תלת עשר מכילן דרחמי — Thirteen Attributes of Mercy.
1171. תלת עשר נהרי אפרסמונא דכיא — Thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil.
1172. תלת עשר נהרי דאפרסמון — Thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil (mystical celestial realm).
1173. תלת עשר נהרי דאפרסמונא — Thirteen rivers of pure balsam oil.
1174. תלתא מוחין — Three aspects of the mind/consciousness.
1175. תפארת (ת״ת) — Tiferet (Beauty/Harmony), the central divine emanation.
1176. תפארת ומלכות — Tiferet and Malkhut.
1177. תפלין דמארי עלמא — Tefillin of the Master of the Universe.
1178. תפלין של אור — Tefillin of light.
1179. תקון הדינים — Rectification of judgments.
1180. תקון הנפש — Rectification of the soul.
1181. תקון הששי — The sixth rectification.
1182. תקון נשמתו — Rectification of the soul.
1183. תקון ס״ד — Tikkun 64.
1184. תקון עליון — Supernal rectification.
1185. תקון שבינה — Rectification of the Divine Presence.
1186. תקונה העליון — Supernal rectification.
1187. תקוני אריך — Rectifications of Arich (configurations of the 'Long-Faced One', a divine aspect in Kabbalah).
1188. תקוני דודין ורעין — Rectifications of lovers and friends.
1189. תקוני דזעיר — Rectifications of Zeir Anpin (the Small-Faced One).
1190. תקוני דיקנא דזעיר — Rectifications of the beard of Zeir Anpin.
1191. תקוני דיקנא יקירא עילאה — Arrangements of the precious supernal beard.
1192. תקוני דיקנא עילאה — Rectifications of the supernal beard.

1193. תקוני דמטרוניתא — Rectification of the Divine Feminine (Matronita).

1194. תקוני הזהר — Tikkunei Zohar.

1195. תקוני התשובה — Rectifications of Repentance.

1196. תקוני זעיר — Rectifications of Zeir Anpin (configurations of the divine countenance).

1197. תקוני נפשות — Rectifications of souls.

1198. תקוני שכינה — Rectifications of the Divine Presence (Shekhinah).

1199. תקוניה — Its rectifications (spiritual repairs).

1200. תקונים החדשים — New Tikkunim (kabbalistic rectifications).

1201. תרייקא — Theriac (medicinal compound used as antidote).

1202. תרין דרועין דמלכא — Two arms of the King.

1203. תרין נביאי קשוט — Two prophets of truth.

1204. תרין קשרין תתאין — Two lower knots (kabbalistic term for spiritual connections in lower realms).

1205. תרנגולת אוכמא — Black rooster.

1206. תרעא דלא פתיח למצותא פתיח לאסיא — A gate that is not open for commandments is open for the physician.

1207. תשובה מעליא — Superior repentance.

1208. תשומת יד — Deposit.

1209. ת״ת עם בינה — Tiferet with Binah.